Walking the American Way

The stories behind the Dhammapada,
set down again across five hundred years of American life

305 stories · written by Claude Opus 5.5 and Claude Fable 5.2

A note on these stories

The Dhammapada is a collection of 423 short verses attributed to the Buddha. A commentary compiled in Sri Lanka in the fifth century tells, for each verse or group of verses, the story of the occasion on which it was spoken: 305 stories in all, of monks and lay people, merchants and kings, grieving mothers and foolish sons.

Each story in this book retells one of those commentary stories somewhere in American history, broadly drawn, from 1492 to the present and from Guam to Newfoundland. Each opens, as the old suttas do, with a version of "Thus have I heard" in the speech of its community. In place of the Buddha's verse, a teacher speaks words from that community's own tradition, quoted exactly from public-domain sources. Each story is followed by a Background with Max Müller's 1881 translation of the verses, a short account of the original commentary story, a map, and notes on the history.

The stories are fiction, written by two AI models, Claude Opus 5.5 and Claude Fable 5.2, working from a shared house style. The history was checked against sources, and each Background says what is documented and what is invented; real public figures appear only at a distance. Errors surely remain.

The online edition, with a timeline and a map: chercherai.github.io/american-dhammapada

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Chapter 1

The Twin-Verses

1.1

Locust Year

> *I will not suffer mine eyes to sleep, nor mine eye-lids to slumber: neither the temples of my head to take any rest.*
> *— Psalm 132:4 (Book of Common Prayer)*

So I have heard it told, on the Choptank.

I. The Oak

Talbot County, Maryland · 1739–1777

Thomas Haddaway had eleven hundred acres on the Choptank, a brick house laid in Flemish bond with the glazed headers making a checkerboard down the gable end, a landing where the sloops took his tobacco down the bay to the London ships, and fifty-three people in the quarters who did the work. He had been married nine years and had no child.

One evening in August he was riding home from swimming his horses in the river and saw at the head of Island Creek a white oak so wide that he got down and walked around it, counting his steps. Twenty-two. It stood alone in a field gone to briars, full of birds. He was not a praying man. But he stood a while in the shade of it and thought that a tree like that must have somebody in it.

The next week he had the briars grubbed out and the oak fenced with split rails, and strips of red cloth tied on the low limbs. Then he stood inside the fence with his hat in his hand and said out loud, so that the men who had done the grubbing heard it and told it afterward in the quarters, *If I get a child of my own I will do you honor all my life.*

His wife was brought to bed of a son the next spring, and they named him Levin. Three years later came another boy, smaller, and they named

him Littleton. The neighbors said, laughing, that the oak was their true father. The old people in the quarters did not laugh about it, and kept the red rags tied on fresh, and Thomas Haddaway let them.

The parents died within a year of each other, in the sixties, and left everything to the two sons. Levin was the older and the quicker. He had read physic one winter in Philadelphia and come home with a case of lancets and a book of receipts, and he doctored the neighborhood, mostly for nothing and sometimes for money when he could get it. That summer, the summer of 1766, the seventeen-year locusts came up out of the ground all over the Eastern Shore, and for a month nobody could hear himself think. Levin married, and his wife died of a fever in 1770, and there were no children. Littleton married and had four. The brothers kept the place together and did well by it, and when the war came they did not go to it.

In the spring of 1777 Levin was riding home from Easton on a Sunday and passed a great many people on the road, white and black, walking in their good clothes with their dinners in baskets and their shoes in their hands to save the leather. He reined in and asked a man where they were all going.

To hear the Methodist.

I'll go too, said Levin, and turned his horse around.

The preaching was in a tobacco barn on the Bay Side road. Levin stood at the back with his hat on. The preacher was a young man from Sussex County named Eli Truitt, twenty-four years old, thin as a rail, with a cough he did not trouble to hide. He did not shout. He talked about giving, and about plain living, and about heaven, and about what the world does to a man who loves it, one thing after the other, in order, as if he were laying out tools on a bench. At the end he talked about the men who had left everything to ride for nothing, and he did not make it sound easy.

Levin found his hat in his hands and did not remember taking it off. He thought: when a man goes out of the world he takes nothing. Not his wheat, not his land, not his people. Not even his own body goes with him. What am I keeping house for?

Afterward he waited until the barn was nearly empty and went up and asked to be taken on as a preacher.

Truitt looked at him a long time. *Is there anybody you ought to ask first?*

I have a brother.

Then ask him.

• • •

He found Littleton in the counting room going over the mill accounts and sat down across the table from him.

Brother, everything in this house and on this place, the land and the landing and the stock and the people, I am giving into your hands. Take it.

And you?

I am going with the Methodists.

Littleton put the pen down. *What are you saying to me? When Mother died, you were my mother. When Father died, you were my father. There is more money in this house than either of us knows what to do with. You can do all the good in the world from right here. Don't do this.*

I heard him, Littleton. I can't go back to the mill accounts now.

Then wait. You're young yet. Wait till you're old, and go then.

When a man is old his own hands and feet won't mind him, said Levin. *How much less his kin. I'm thirty-seven. I'm going now.*

Littleton wept, and followed him out to the yard, and wept there. Levin rode to Easton the next week and signed it all over before a justice. The land, the house, the landing, the mill, and the people in the quarters. On paper he walked out of Talbot County owning a horse, a Bible, and two shirts. He had given the people in the quarters to his brother along with the plows. It took him some years to see that this was a different thing from letting them go.

II. The Swamp

The Peninsula · 1777–1782

He rode five years. He rode the Dorset circuit and the Kent and the Sussex, preaching every day and twice on Sundays in barns

AND KITCHENS AND UNDER TREES, AND SLEPT IN LOFTS WITH the hired men. They were dangerous years for a Methodist on the Peninsula. Many of the preachers would not take the state oath, and the patriots took them for Tories. Levin saw a preacher locked in the Easton jail who went on preaching through the grate to the people in the street, until the town said that if they did not let him out he would convert the whole county. Levin himself spent one night in the Cambridge jail with his saddlebags for a pillow.

In 1780 the Conference in Baltimore resolved that slavery was contrary to the law of God, man, and nature, and required every traveling preacher who held slaves to promise to set them free. Levin held none. He had given them to his brother. Nothing was required of him.

In May of 1782, at the Conference in Baltimore, he found Eli Truitt sitting on a bench in the yard of the preaching house with a handkerchief to his mouth, and sat down beside him.

Brother Truitt. How many duties are there in this work?

Two. The books and the closet. The books is the Bible and Mr. Wesley's sermons, and the Greek if you can get it, five hours a day. The closet is going in, and shutting the door, and staying until you are made perfect in love.

I came to it too old for the Greek, Levin said. *I'll never be a scholar. But I can do the other. Give me something to go in with.*

Seek to be made perfect in love. Not when you are dying. Now. This year.

Levin took eleven young men with him, preachers on trial and exhorters, all of them younger than he was, and rode south sixty miles to the edge of the Great Cypress Swamp, where Maryland and Delaware come together in the black water and nobody living there was much troubled about which was which. The settlement at Burnt Branch was a dozen cabins of shingle-getters. They dug cypress logs out of the peat and rived them into shingles for the Snow Hill market, and in dry summers they burned the peat off to come at the logs, so that the whole swamp smelled of smoke and the fire sometimes got loose and went under the ground and burned there for months.

The shingle-getters fed the preachers fried fish and hominy, and watched them keep their rules, and asked where they were going.

Somewhere to winter.

Winter here, said the shingle-getters. *If you'll stay till spring, we'll keep your rules too.*

In two weeks they had raised a log preaching house with a chimney of mud and sticks, and a cabin for the preachers behind it with twelve bunks of riven cypress. A doctor named Hudson who rode the country between Snow Hill and the swamp came out to see what the excitement was, and stayed for preaching, and afterward shook Levin's hand.

Where a dozen men sleep together, somebody's going to take sick. Send for me. I won't charge preachers.

On the first night of their winter, in the new cabin, by the fire, Levin asked the eleven how they meant to keep the season.

Sitting, standing, walking, and lying down, said the youngest, and they laughed. *Same as anybody.*

Is that right? said Levin. *We came out here from the Conference with a charge. You don't get perfect love by halves. Let every man be careful.*

And you, Brother Haddaway?

I'll sit and stand and walk, he said. *I'll not lie down this winter.* And he opened the Prayer Book that he still carried from the old days and read them the Psalm.

> *Lord, remember David: and all his trouble; How he sware unto the Lord: and vowed a vow unto the Almighty God of Jacob; I will not come within the tabernacle of mine house: nor climb up into my bed; I will not suffer mine eyes to sleep, nor mine eye-lids to slumber: neither the temples of my head to take any rest; Until I find out a place for the temple of the Lord: an habitation for the mighty God of Jacob.*
>
> *— Psalm 132:1–5 (Book of Common Prayer)*

The bunk with his name cut in it stayed empty. He sat the nights on a three-legged stool by the fire, and when he felt himself going he stood, and when his knees went he walked, up and down the dirt floor, nine steps and nine back, until he had worn a path in it.

III. Tutty

Burnt Branch · winter, 1782–83

By the first of December his eyes had begun to run. The water came out of them all day and all night, the way it comes out of a cracked jar, and they were red to the lids and swollen, and every morning they were gummed shut and he had to wet them open with his fingers. The peat was still smoldering in the swamp from the summer, and the cabin chimney drew badly, and there was smoke in everything.

The young men saw his face and asked what was the matter.

The wind cuts my eyes, brothers.

Dr. Hudson said to send for him.

Send, then.

Hudson sent back a little pot of ointment of tutty, the grey kind that comes in a white jar, and said to lay it along the lids at night. Levin laid it on, sitting on his stool. A week later Hudson met him on the Snow Hill road.

I hear the wind is at your eyes, Mr. Haddaway.

That's so.

Did you use the tutty?

I did.

And how are they?

The same.

Hudson frowned. One pot of tutty had never failed him. *When you put it on, were you sitting up, or lying down?*

Levin said nothing. Hudson asked again, and a third time, and Levin sat his horse and did not say a word, and that afternoon Hudson rode out to Burnt Branch himself. The preachers were out. He went into the cabin and saw the twelve bunks and the one bunk bare, and the stool by the fire, and the path in the dirt, nine steps and nine back, worn down an inch below the rest of the floor.

He was waiting when Levin came in at dark.

Mr. Haddaway, I'll ask you once more. Were you lying down?

Silence.

Sir, you can't do God's work without a body to do it in. Lie down at night and you'll keep your eyes. Sit up like this and you'll lose them. I've seen it.

Go your way, friend, Levin said. *I'll take counsel and decide it myself.*

He had nobody there to take counsel with. So when Hudson had gone he sat down on his stool and took counsel with himself, out loud.

Now, Levin Haddaway. Tell me which you'll keep. Your eyes, or what you came out here for? Every man that ever lived has lost his eyes in the end, if not before the grave then in it. And how many men in all that time ever got a winter like this one, with nothing to do but this? You said you'd not lie down. Let the eyes go, then. Keep the other.

And a little later, rocking on the stool, he said it again another way. *Your eyes are going, and your ears, and the whole of you is going. All of it that hangs on a body is going. Why are you careless, Levin?*

He laid on the tutty, sitting. In the morning he rode out. Hudson met him on the road.

Did you use it?

I did.

And?

The same.

Sitting, or lying?

Silence.

Then you are no good to yourself, and no good to me, Hudson said. *From now on don't tell people Hudson treated you, and I won't tell them I did.* And he did not come back.

Levin went home to the cabin and sat down. *Given up by the doctor,* he said to himself. *Bound for the grave anyhow. Why be careless now?*

• • •

It was a night toward the end of January, past the middle of the night, in the cold that comes before the birds. The fire had burned down to a red eye. The eleven were asleep. Levin sat on his stool with his elbows on his knees and his face in his hands, and he was singing under his breath, the way he had sung it a thousand times on a thousand roads, not thinking about it any more than a man thinks about his own feet.

Long my imprison'd Spirit lay,
Fast bound in Sin and Nature's Night:
Thine Eye diffus'd a quick'ning Ray;
I woke; the Dungeon flam'd with Light;
My Chains fell off, my Heart was free,
I rose, went forth, and follow'd Thee.

— Charles Wesley, "Free Grace" (1739)

Somewhere in the fourth line his eyes went out. And the other thing happened, in the same moment, so that he was never afterward able to tell anybody which had come first, or whether they were two things at all. He said only that the cabin went dark and he was full of light, and that there was nothing left in him that wanted anything, and that he had sat there on the stool until morning without once thinking of lying down, because there was no longer anyone in him who was tired.

When the young men woke, he was sitting where he always sat.

Brother Haddaway. It's time to ride.

Is it time?

It's light out.

Then go on, brothers.

And you?

My sight's gone.

They came and looked into his eyes and their own eyes filled. *Don't worry, brother. We'll see to you.* They rode the round without him, and at every cabin people asked where Mr. Haddaway was, and when they heard, they sent mush and buttermilk back that same morning. In the afternoon the women came in a body and knelt on the dirt floor around his stool and wept, and some of them shouted, and then they wiped their faces and said, *We'll see to you, Mr. Haddaway,* and from that day there was mush on the preaching house step every morning before light.

He talked to the eleven that winter more than he ever had, and they did what he said, and before the frost was out of the ground every one of them had found the same.

IV. The Coat

Burnt Branch and Talbot County · April and May, 1783

THE PEACE CAME IN APRIL. A SHINGLE WAGON BROUGHT THE news back from Snow Hill, and the shingle-getters fired off every gun in the settlement, and that week the young men came to Levin together.

Brother, the Conference sits in Baltimore at the end of May. We want to go up and see Brother Truitt.

He had thought about it already. Between the swamp and the Choptank there were sixty miles of bad road, and thickets a man could lose himself in for a week, and men in the woods who had gone there in the war and had not come out. If he went with them they would have to lead him every step and go hungry for it.

You go on ahead.

And you?

I'm weak, and you'd only be slow on my account. Go on. When you get to my brother, tell him I've lost my eyes, and he'll send somebody down for me. Give my love to Brother Truitt, and to all of them.

They argued, and he would not hear it, and at last they asked his pardon for arguing and went. The people of Burnt Branch walked with them out to the end of the causeway, crying, and stood there until they were out of sight.

• • •

They came up the Choptank road in the second week of May, and Littleton Haddaway knew them by their coats before they were through the gate.

Where is my brother?

They told him. He went down on the brick walk with his face against it and wept, and the eleven young men stood around him not knowing where to look.

When he could he sat up. *What do I do?*

He wants somebody sent down to lead him home.

My sister's boy is here. Kemp. Kemp Dawson. Send him.

Kemp was nineteen and big and had been reading law in Chestertown without much result. The young preachers looked him over.

Sixty miles through that country is no road for a boy alone, they said. *But a Methodist preacher goes anywhere on the Peninsula. Every door that has one of ours behind it opens to him, and every man on the road knows there is nothing in his saddlebags worth the stealing. Let him take the Rules, and put on the coat, and go down that way.*

So for two weeks they taught Kemp Dawson the General Rules of the United Societies, and how to give out a hymn two lines at a time, and on the fifteenth day they put him into a plain black coat with no buttons on the cuffs and pointed him south.

He walked it in four days. At the edge of the swamp an old man sitting on a shingle bolt with a pipe asked who he was, and when Kemp said, *The blind preacher's sister's son,* knocked out the pipe and took him in. Kemp stayed two weeks. He cut the wood and drew the water and led his uncle up and down the path in the dirt, and the people at Burnt Branch said what a fine young preacher, and he did not tell them otherwise.

At the end of the two weeks he said, *Uncle Littleton wants you home. Let's go.*

Levin stood up and held out his staff, a peeled hickory sapling the shingle-getters had cut for him.

Take hold of the end of it, then.

The whole of Burnt Branch walked a mile beside them into the trees, and then stopped, and he heard them crying behind him for a long way.

V. The Lightwood Song

The Cypress Swamp · June, 1783

THEY HAD COME MOST OF THE WAY THROUGH THE SWAMP BY the old shingle road when they passed the camp at Bald Cypress, where Levin had preached the first autumn. Beyond the camp, off in the trees, a woman was singing as she gathered lightwood for her fire. Levin could hear the dry sticks snapping and the voice going on over them, not loud, a long sad song about a young man dying of love and a hard-hearted girl,

BARBARA ALLEN, THE ONE EVERYBODY KNOWS. HER VOICE went into the woods and came back.

There is no sound on earth that goes into a young man like a woman's voice. Kemp heard it and stopped walking, and stood there, and Levin felt the end of the staff go loose in his hand.

Wait here a minute, Uncle. I have some business.

He went off through the trees. Levin stood in the road. The singing went on a little longer. Then it stopped, all at once, in the middle of a line, and did not start again.

Levin stood with the staff and thought: I heard somebody singing just now, and it was a woman. And the boy is a long time about his business. And he knew.

After a while Kemp came back through the leaves.

All right, Uncle, let's be off.

Kemp. Have you done wrong?

Kemp said nothing. Levin asked him three times, and three times Kemp stood in the road and did not answer, and Levin could hear him breathing.

Then a man like you will never take hold of the end of my staff.

Kemp stood a while. Then Levin heard the black coat come off, and heard it drop in the road.

I was never a preacher, Uncle. I only put the coat on to get down here safe. I'm what I always was. Come on now, take my arm.

A sinner is a sinner, Levin said, *in a black coat or a brown one. You couldn't keep the Rules two weeks in a preacher's coat. Will you be a better man for taking it off? You will never hold the end of my staff.*

Uncle, there's men in these woods that would kill you for your shoes. And you're blind. How will you live out here?

Don't trouble about that. Whether I lie down right here and die, or wander around in these woods till I fall in the water, I will not go with you. And he said, quietly, to nobody, *I am blind, and I have come through a swamp to get here. I'll lie down here and go no farther. I won't keep company with a fool.*

Kemp heard it. He made a sound Levin would remember, a sound like something tearing. *God forgive me. What have I done.* And he went off into

the swamp, running, crashing through the gallberry, crying out, and Levin heard him for a long time, and then he did not hear him.

The black coat lay in the road. Levin stood beside it with the staff.

VI. The Short Way

The same day

He stood long enough for the birds to come back. Then somebody was near him in the road, shuffling his feet in the leaves the way a man does who doesn't want to come on you by surprise.

Who is it?

A traveler, sir, going up to Talbot. Where are you bound?

To Talbot too.

Then let's go together.

I'm slow. I'll keep you back.

I'm in no hurry, the man said. *And it's a good work to help a preacher on his way. Let's go together.*

He had a voice like anybody's. Levin thought, this is some good Methodist from up the road. *All right. Take hold of the end of the staff.*

The man took it, and they walked.

Levin knew the roads by their feel. Sand and black muck and the logs of the causeway, then the long sand ridges, then the clay. It seemed to him the ground changed under his feet faster than ground should. It was evening when he heard a gun, far off, and then drums, and church bells under the drums, and he stopped in the road.

Where is that?

That's Easton, sir. They're still firing for the peace.

Easton. Levin stood very still. *Friend, when I came down that road last fall it took us the better part of three days.*

I know a short way.

And Levin knew then that whoever had the end of his staff was no man.

The traveler took him up the Choptank road in the dusk and turned in at the head of Island Creek, where the old oak stood, and brought him to

a little cabin of logs and cedar shakes just outside the oak's fence. Littleton had built it in March, when the first word came that his eyes were going, and nobody had slept in it yet. The traveler sat him on the bed and went out.

Then he went up to the big house as Jacob Kerr, who had the next place up the river and had been Littleton's friend since they were boys, and stood at the foot of the porch steps in the dark and called up. *Littleton! Did you know your brother's home? He's sitting in the cabin you built him.*

And he went away. The next Sunday Littleton went over to thank Jacob Kerr, and Kerr, who was a truthful man, said he had been laid up that whole week with the gout in both feet and had not been off his own place since Easter, and his wife said so too. The people in the quarters were not surprised. They said the old oak had sent somebody to bring its boy home, and that it was about time.

• • •

Littleton ran the whole way down from the house in the dark and went into the cabin and fell down on the floor at his brother's feet, and wrapped his arms around his brother's knees, and cried until he couldn't.

I knew, he said. *I knew this would happen. That's why I wouldn't give you my leave. I knew it.*

Levin put his hand on his brother's head.

A week later Littleton rode into Easton with Isaac and Daniel from the quarters and two witnesses, and before a justice of the peace he signed two deeds under his hand and seal, as the law required, setting them free. Both men were under fifty years of age and able to work and gain a sufficient living, as the law also required. Isaac had been leading the black class at the Bay Side meeting for three years, and Daniel sang in it. Littleton asked them, riding home, if they would see to his brother, and said he would pay wages and give them the ground around the cabin.

Isaac rode a long way without answering.

We'll see to him, he said at last. *I knew him before you did, near about. I was ten years old when he went to Philadelphia.* Then he said, *And the others?*

Littleton did not have an answer, and rode the rest of the way home without one, and Isaac let him.

VII. The Brood

Island Creek · June, 1783

The Conference rose in Baltimore at the end of May, and three of the young preachers coming down the Peninsula turned in at the Haddaway landing because they had heard there was a blind preacher there who had been made perfect in a swamp. They came up the creek road at evening, and a storm came up off the bay with them, and they turned back to the big house and said they would go down to the cabin in the morning. It rained hard until midnight. Then it stopped.

Levin had always been a walker. In the last hours of the night he came out and walked the brick path Littleton had laid for him, from the cabin door to the fence of the oak, forty steps and forty back, until the birds started.

That night, all over Talbot County, the ground opened. It had been seventeen years. The rain had softened the earth and the warm night had come after it, and out of every inch of ground under every tree the locusts came up, brown and blind and wet, by the thousands, and crawled up whatever was nearest to split their backs and come out of themselves. They came up through the cracks between the bricks of the path. They crawled across it toward the oak. Levin walked up and down on them in the dark and did not know they were there. Nobody had swept the path. Isaac was asleep.

In the morning the three young preachers came down from the house and found the brick walk covered from end to end with them, crushed, and the oak above it so thick with the living ones that the bark seemed to crawl.

Who walked here?

Isaac was in the doorway. *Mr. Levin. He walks every night.*

The oldest of them was twenty-two. *Look what the perfect man has done,* he said. *When he had his eyes he sat up all night and harmed nothing. Now*

he's lost them he goes walking up and down in the dark killing God's creatures by the hundred. Perfect, they say.

Eli Truitt came up the creek road that noon on his way to Dorset. He had charge of all that country now, and he was thinner than ever, and he got down from his horse slowly, and the three young men met him at the gate and told him.

Did you see him kill them? Truitt said.

No.

No more did he see them. Truitt walked past them to the path and stood looking at it. *Mr. Wesley says that nothing is sin, strictly speaking, but a voluntary transgression of a known law of God. He didn't know they were there. Go and look at your own feet, brothers, if you want somebody to try.*

The oldest one said, *Then tell us this. If he's been made perfect, why did God take his eyes?*

Truitt looked toward the cabin door. Levin was sitting just inside it, in his chair, and he had heard everything, and after a moment he nodded once.

I'll tell you, Truitt said. *He told it himself at his first love feast, standing up in front of four hundred people.*

• • •

The year he came home from Philadelphia with his lancets, a free woman of color in Easton named Hester Copper came to him because her eyes were failing. She washed for people, and she couldn't see to wash. He asked what she would pay. She had nothing. She said if he made her eyes well she would bind herself to him for seven years, herself and her children with her. He said that would do.

He laid tutty on her eyes, the same as Hudson sent him in the swamp, and in a week they were well.

Then she thought about it. She had seen free people bound out in Talbot County before. She had seen their time run on past seven years, and their papers lost, and their children carried off and sold for somebody's debts. She was not going to put her children's names on any paper. So when he came by to see how she did, she told him her eyes were worse than before.

He knew she was lying. He didn't want her seven years. He wanted her to pay. So he went home and mixed oil of vitriol into a pot of salve and carried it back to her and told her to lay it on her eyes that night, and she did, and they went out like a candle.

That was the summer of 1766, Truitt said. *The last time these came up out of the ground.*

The young men stood on the path. The noise in the oak had come up while he talked and was everywhere now, like a saw blade, like the whole county humming.

A wheel follows the ox that draws it, Truitt said. *It follows him all the way down the road. He's not sorry about his eyes. He'll tell you so himself.* And he said the Psalm to them the way all of them had learned it as children, out of the Prayer Book, before there were any Methodists.

> *The heathen are sunk down in the pit that they made: in the same net which they hid privily, is their foot taken. The Lord is known to execute judgment: the ungodly is trapped in the work of his own hands.*
>
> *— Psalm 9:15–16 (Book of Common Prayer)*

VIII. The Husks

Island Creek · the same evening

When the preachers had ridden on, Levin asked Isaac to take him out to the oak.

Isaac took the end of the staff and led him in through the gate of the old fence, where the red rags still hung on the low limbs, faded to pink, and sat him down with his back against the trunk. Levin put his hands out on the bark on either side of him. It was covered with the husks. They were dry already, and light as paper, each one hooked into the bark by its little feet and split straight down the back where the thing inside had climbed out of it and gone on up into the leaves, and the leaves overhead were roaring with them.

He sat a long time feeling them. Then he asked Isaac whether Hester Copper was living.

She's living. She stays with her daughter, in Easton, back of the courthouse. Will you take me there tomorrow?

Isaac did not answer right away. He looked at the man sitting against the oak with his white eyes and his hands full of empty shells.

I'll take you, he said. *What she does about it is up to her.*

In the morning Isaac took the tip of the staff, and they went up the Easton road together, slowly, with the noise in every tree on both sides of them, and the dry husks coming loose from the bark as they passed and falling in the road, and crackling under their feet.

Background

The verse

> *All that we are is the result of what we have thought: it is founded on our thoughts, it is made up of our thoughts. If a man speaks or acts with an evil thought, pain follows him, as the wheel follows the foot of the ox that draws the carriage.*
>
> Dhammapada 1, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Mahā Pāla is the elder son of a rich man of Sāvatthī who got his children by a vow to the spirit of a great tree. He hears the Buddha teach, gives his whole estate to his younger brother, and becomes a monk. Spending the rains in a border village with sixty companions, he vows not to lie down for three months. His eyes fail, a physician's ointment does nothing, and one night his sight and his defilements go out together, and he wakes an arahant, blind. On the road home his nephew, newly ordained to make the journey safe, leaves him in the forest for a woman he hears singing as she gathers firewood, and Sakka, king of the gods, takes the end of his staff and brings him to Sāvatthī by a short way. When visiting monks find insects crushed on his walking path after rain, the Buddha says that he did not see them and meant no killing, and that his blindness came from a former life in which, as a physician, he blinded a woman who had cheated him of his fee. Read the full commentary story, or a shorter telling of the story of Thera Cakkhupāla.

Talbot County, Maryland

The Eastern Shore of Maryland, 1777–1783

Methodism grew quickly during the Revolution on the Delmarva Peninsula, between the Chesapeake and the Delaware. Many of its preachers would not swear the state oaths, and patriots suspected them of loyalism. Francis Asbury spent most of a year sheltered in Delaware, Joseph Hartley was jailed in Talbot County and preached to the townspeople through the bars, and Freeborn Garrettson was jailed at Cambridge in 1780, sleeping on the floor with his saddlebags for a pillow. That same year the preachers' conference declared slavery "contrary to the law of God, man, and nature" and required traveling preachers who held slaves to promise to free them. By 1783 the movement had eighty-two traveling preachers. The early conference minutes are reprinted in Nathan Bangs's history of the Methodist Episcopal Church. Mr. Wesley's definition of sin, "a voluntary transgression of a known law of God," comes from a 1772 letter to Elizabeth Bennis.

Under a Maryland act of 1752, a master could free an enslaved person only by a deed under hand and seal, witnessed by two people, acknowledged before a justice and recorded within six months, and only if the person freed was no older than fifty and able to earn a living. The seventeen-year cicadas of Brood X, which colonists called locusts, came up across Maryland and Delaware in 1766 and again in 1783; Benjamin Banneker remembered both emergences. The Great Cypress Swamp on the Maryland–Delaware line, now the largest forest on the Peninsula, was cut for shingle timber and drained for farming, and one peat fire burned there so long that people called it the Burnt Swamp. Ointment of tutty, a crude zinc oxide salve, was mainly used for sore eyes.

After the story of the Elder Cakkhupāla from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 1). The original. Scripture from the Book of Common Prayer (1662), with a hymn by Charles Wesley (1739). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.2

Uncle No

and they will depart this life with tranquil minds.
— Smaller Sukhâvatî-vyûha 10

Tôi nghe như vầy, on Bolsa Avenue.

I. Uncle No

Westminster, California · 1980–2008

Phạm Văn Lộc came out of Vietnam in 1980 on a fishing boat with fourteen taels of gold leaf sewn flat into the waistband of his trousers, paid nine of them to the boat owner, two to a guard on the beach, one to a man on Pulau Bidong for a place in the shade, and arrived in Orange County with two. He never forgot the arithmetic. In twenty-eight years he never again paid one cent for anything he could get for nothing or do with his own hands.

By 2008 he owned two nail salons on Brookhurst Street and a ranch house on a side street off Bolsa, paid for in cash. He did his own taxes, his own plumbing and his own haircuts, and they looked it. He drove a 1994 Camry with a cracked dashboard. At Tết he put one-dollar bills in the red envelopes, new ones, so they would crackle. He had never given the temple so much as an orange, and the whole of Little Saigon called him Chú Không, Uncle No, because no was the answer to everything, and he did not mind it. A man named No keeps what he has.

What he had, he kept mostly in a floor safe under the carpet in the bedroom closet, in gold. He did not trust banks. In Saigon he had watched the banks close and the money change overnight and the people who had trusted it stand in the street with sacks of paper. Gold you could sew into your pants. In 2008, when the banks in America began to fall

down one after another and the price of gold went over a thousand dollars an ounce, he went to the jewelry stores on Bolsa every Saturday with cash and bought more, and came home and knelt in the closet and turned the dial.

His wife, Thu, did the books for the salons and said nothing. They had one child, a son, Bảo, which means treasure. Lộc loved him the way he loved the gold, which was entirely.

When Bảo was fourteen he wanted diamond studs in his ears like the other boys at school. Lộc said no. Bảo asked for a year. At last Lộc went to a jewelry store on Bolsa and bought one chỉ of gold, a tenth of a tael, a little flat bar like a stick of gum, and when the jeweler said forty dollars to make it into studs, he said no. He took it home to the garage and cut it in two with a hacksaw and beat each half round on the vise with a ball-peen hammer and filed them and soldered posts on them with a torch from the hardware store. They came out lumpy, not quite the same size, and very yellow. Bảo wore them anyway. He wore them every day. The boys at school called him Bông Tai, Earrings, and after a while everybody did, and that was his name.

II. Yellow

Spring, 2009

In March of the year he turned sixteen, Bảo's eyes went yellow.

It started as tiredness. He fell asleep in class. He stopped eating. Then one morning Thu looked at him across the breakfast table and put down her spoon, because the whites of his eyes were the color of old piano keys, and by the end of the week his skin had gone the same color, and his urine was dark as tea.

Anh. He's sick. Take him to the doctor.

A doctor means the hospital. The hospital means three thousand dollars before they say hello. We have no insurance. You want to give them the house?

Then what will you do?

I'll take care of it, said Lộc. *Without throwing money in the street.*

He went to the herb shops on Bolsa, one after the other, and asked at each one what they gave for yellow eyes, as if he were asking about the weather. At each one they told him nhân trần, and gardenia, and rhubarb root, and he wrote it down. He bought the cheapest he could find and brewed it himself on the back burner in an old aluminum pot, and the whole house smelled of it, bitter, like wet hay. Bảo drank it. Bảo got worse. By the middle of April he could not get up the stairs, and then he could not get out of bed, and his belly swelled, and he slept most of the day and did not always know where he was when he woke.

Lộc saw then that his son was going to die. He called a doctor he knew from the salons, a man with a clinic in a strip mall on Magnolia, and asked him to come to the house after hours, as a favor, for cash.

The doctor came at nine at night in his golf shirt and looked at Bảo's eyes and pressed his belly and looked at his fingernails, and stood up.

Anh Lộc, he needs a hospital. A liver unit. Tonight. Maybe a transplant list. There's nothing I can do here. I have patients at seven in the morning. He would not take the money. He went out without looking at either of them.

Lộc stood in the kitchen a long time after the car was gone. When a boy is dying, he thought, people come. The aunts come, the cousins come, the neighbors, the whole salon. They come into the house and sit down and drink tea and look at everything. The television. The new refrigerator. The closet door. They talk afterward, at the market, at the temple, in the salons, and somebody's nephew hears it, and one night men in ski masks come through the back slider with a pistol and duct tape and make you open the safe. He had heard of it happening on this street. Everybody had.

The next morning he cleared out the garage, set up the folding cot, put the electric fan beside it, and carried his son out to it in his arms, because there was more air out there, he said, and the boy was too hot in the house. He left the big door up. Anyone who came to see Bông Tai could see him from the driveway.

III. The Garage

Before dawn, the last day of April

TWO STREETS OVER THERE WAS A TEMPLE IN A RANCH HOUSE. The lawn had been taken out and gravel put down, and in the middle of the gravel stood a white statue of Quan Âm taller than the mailbox, pouring water from a vase, and on the porch there was a rack for shoes. Three nuns lived there in gray robes with shaved heads. The neighborhood called the eldest of them, who was not old, Sư Cô Tịnh Liên. Every morning at five-thirty she walked to the bakery on Bolsa to buy bread for the others and walked back, and she went by the Phạm house both ways. That morning, the other nuns said afterward, she went out a quarter of an hour early and took the long way around, which she never did.

Old Mr. Huỳnh across the street was always out in his driveway at that hour, doing his exercises, and he is the one who told it.

He said the boy was lying on the cot in the open garage with his face to the wall, toward the house, where his father had put him. He said the nun came up the sidewalk in the dark with her bag of bread, and stopped at the foot of the driveway, and looked in. The boy did not see her. Then, Mr. Huỳnh said, a light came out from her. Not from a flashlight. From her. It went up the driveway the way headlights do when a car turns in, and it lay across the cot and across the back wall of the garage, over the rakes and the water heater and the shelves of motor oil, so that every one of them threw a shadow. He said it was the color of the inside of a lemon. He said he stood there with his arms out in front of him like a fool and could not put them down.

The boy turned over, slowly, to see what it was.

He saw the nun standing at the end of his father's driveway with her bag of bread. He had passed that temple every day of his life on his way to the bus. He had never gone in. He had never taken a stick of incense there, or a bag of oranges, or sat on the floor and listened, because his father said they wanted money, and his father had known everything. Now he could not lift his hands.

He looked at her, and that was all he could do, and he did it with everything that was left in him.

Mr. Huỳnh said the nun put her palms together, and bowed to the boy in the garage, as if he were somebody, and said something he did not catch, and then said, quite clearly, *Đủ rồi.* That's enough. And turned and went on up the street with her bread, and the light went with her.

Bảo lay looking at the place where she had been. He did not turn back to the wall. Somewhere behind the houses on Bolsa the sky was going grey. He was thinking of her face, and he went on thinking of it, and somewhere in the thinking, quietly, the way a car settles when you turn the engine off, he died.

Mr. Huỳnh had taught school in Huế before the war ended, and he read English at the Westminster library every afternoon. A week later he found a passage in an old book there and copied it out by hand, and he kept it folded in his wallet for the rest of his life and showed it to anyone who would stand still.

> *O Bhagavat, if those beings who have directed their thought towards the highest perfect knowledge in other worlds, and who, after having heard my name, when I have obtained the Bodhi (knowledge), have meditated on me with serene thoughts; if at the moment of their death, after having approached them, surrounded by an assembly of Bhikshus, I should not stand before them, worshipped by them, that is, so that their thoughts should not be troubled, then may I not obtain the highest perfect knowledge.*
>
> *— Larger Sukhâvatî-vyûha 8*

IV. The Wall

The memorial park on Beach Boulevard · May and June

They cremated him on a Thursday. Lộc paid for the cheapest container the funeral home would allow and argued about the price of the chapel. He took the gold studs out of his son's ears himself

BEFORE THEY CLOSED THE LID AND PUT THEM IN HIS SHIRT pocket, and he did not know why he did it, and he kept them there.

The urn went into a niche in the long granite wall at the memorial park on Beach Boulevard, the third row from the top, with a little brass vase and a photograph behind glass of Bảo in his school shirt, grinning, with the lumpy studs showing.

Then something happened to Uncle No that nobody on the side street had expected. He began to go to the wall every day. He went before he opened the salons and again after he closed them. He stood in front of the niche in his work clothes with his hands at his sides and cried out loud, in front of anybody, the way the old women cry at funerals in the countryside, and the groundskeepers learned to leave that row for last. *Bảo ơi. Con ở đâu?* Bảo. Where are you? He stopped eating. He let the salons run themselves. He stood in front of the wall in the sun until the security guard came and asked him to go home.

Thu bought the paper offerings for the forty-ninth day. A paper house with a two-car garage. Paper clothes, paper sneakers, a paper cell phone, bundles of paper gold. And at the shop on Bolsa she found a paper car, a long gold car with silver trim, a beautiful thing, sixty dollars. Lộc saw the price and said no and bought the twelve-dollar one, flat, with the wheels printed on the sides. They burned it all in a steel drum in the back yard, and he watched his son's car curl up and go black, and cried again, and did not know whether it was for the boy or the sixty dollars, and that made him cry harder.

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Where Bảo was, it was very bright.

He had woken the way you wake from a nap in the back seat of a car, not knowing for a moment where you are, and it was exactly as the old women at the temple had always said, the ones he had never listened to. There were lakes with golden sand on the bottom and stairs going down into them of gold and silver and beryl and crystal. There were trees made of jewels that rang when the wind went through them. There were lotuses on the water as big around as the wheels of a chariot. He was stand-

ing beside one of them, and he was wearing his studs, and they were not lumpy anymore.

He wondered how he had gotten there. He had never done one thing for it. He had not kept a single precept on purpose or given the temple one orange. And then he remembered the light in the garage, and the nun at the foot of the driveway, and the one look, and he knew.

Then he looked back the way you look back over your shoulder at a house you have moved out of, and he saw his father standing in front of a granite wall on Beach Boulevard in the heat, crying.

That man, Bảo thought. *He wouldn't buy me medicine because it cost money, and now he stands there every day and cries. Somebody has to straighten him out.*

V. Wheels

Beach Boulevard · late June

It was a weekday, past noon, and the memorial park was empty except for the sprinklers. Lộc stood at the wall saying what he always said. After a while he became aware that someone else was crying, not far off. A boy, at the end of the same row of niches, sixteen or so, in a school shirt, with both hands over his face, sobbing like a child.

Lộc thought, I am crying because my son is dead. What is that boy crying for? He went down the row.

Hey. Em. Why are you crying? You're young. You have everything. What's the matter?

The boy took his hands away from his face. He looked very much like Bảo. He wore two gold studs in his ears. Lộc could not stop looking at them.

I have a car, the boy said. *A beautiful car. All gold. But it doesn't have any wheels. I've looked everywhere and I can't find wheels for it, and without wheels I'm going to die.*

Lộc wiped his face on his sleeve. Something in his chest that had been closed since April came open a crack, and what came through was the

oldest thing in him, the thing that had sewn gold into its trousers and got off the boat with two taels left.

That's all? Wheels? I'll get you wheels. Tell me what kind. Gold? Jade? Chrome? Silver? Tell me, and I'll buy them for you.

The boy looked at him with a strange expression. *How big a set?*

As big as you want.

The boy pointed up. It was a clear day, and the sun was over the freeway, and very faint in the blue on the other side of the sky, the way it is some afternoons, there was the moon.

I want those two. The sun and the moon. My car is gold, and those would match.

Lộc stared at him. *Are you crazy? You're crying for something nobody can have. You'll die crying, and you still won't get the sun and the moon.*

But you can see them, the boy said. *Look. Right there. Both of them. Your son, nobody can see. He's not anywhere. So which one of us is crazy, Uncle? Me, crying for something that's up there in the sky, or you, crying for somebody who isn't here?*

Lộc stood in the sprinklers' hiss with his mouth open. Then he said, very slowly, *You're right. I'm the crazy one. I'm a child crying for the moon.*

And it was as if he had been standing in a fire for two months, he said later, a fire somebody kept feeding with cooking oil, and someone had poured a bucket of cold water over his head. The thing that had been stuck in his chest since April, like a fishbone in the throat, came out. He breathed. He stopped crying. He stood there in the hot afternoon, dry-eyed, cool.

Who are you, em? Whose son are you?

Ba, the boy said. *It's me. Bông Tai. The one you burned.*

Lộc did not fall down. He was surprised, afterward, that he had not fallen down.

Where are you?

In the West. In the Land of Ultimate Bliss. The one they talk about at the temple.

How? You never went to the temple. You never gave anything. You never kept a precept in your life. I know. I raised you.

I was sick in the garage, Bảo said. *I couldn't lift my hands. The Sư Cô from the temple on the next street came by with her bread, and she looked at me, and I looked at her. That was all. I looked at her with my whole heart. That's all I did.*

Lộc felt his whole body go warm, from his feet up, the way it goes warm when you get into a bath. *Is that true? One look?*

It's true. Ba, listen to me. Go to her. Take refuge. Keep the five precepts. Don't kill anything, don't take anything that isn't given, don't lie, don't drink, don't run around on Má. You have all that gold in the closet. Give some away. Invite her to the house, feed her, ask her whatever you want to ask. You'll see.

I'll do it, Lộc said. *Everything you said. You're my teacher now.*

And there was nobody at the end of the row, only the sprinklers ticking around on the grass and the moon very faint over the freeway.

VI. The Meal

The house on the side street · a Sunday in July

He went home and told Thu they were inviting the Sư Cô and the other nuns to the house to be fed. Thu sat down on the kitchen floor.

Then he walked the two streets to the temple in his work clothes. He did not take off his shoes on the porch, or bow to the Buddha on the altar, or greet anyone. He found Sư Cô Tịnh Liên in the kitchen cutting tofu and stood in the doorway.

Sư Cô. Come with the others and eat at my house on Sunday. I want to ask you something.

She looked at him, and at his shoes, and put down the knife, and said yes.

He spent more money that week than he had spent in twenty-eight years. He hired a vegetarian caterer on Bolsa and ordered everything on the list. He bought new folding tables and borrowed chairs from the salons, and a white cloth for the table where the nuns would sit, and set up an altar in the living room with Bảo's photograph and a bowl of oranges stacked in a pyramid, the most expensive oranges in the market.

The whole side street came, and half of Bolsa. They came the way people come to see an accident. Some of them came because Chú Không was paying for a meal and they wanted to see it with their own eyes. Some of them came because they had heard he was going to ask the Sư Cô a question, and they had decided that Uncle No would ask her something she could not answer, and they wanted to be there when he did. And some of them came because they had heard about Mr. Huỳnh and the light in the driveway, and they wanted to see what the Sư Cô would do. The house filled up and the garage filled up and people stood out in the driveway in the heat, holding paper plates.

When the nuns had eaten, and the plates were cleared, Lộc took a low stool from the kitchen and set it down in front of Sư Cô Tịnh Liên and sat on it, so that his head was lower than hers, and asked his question in front of everybody.

Sư Cô. Can a person be born in the Pure Land without ever giving anything to the temple? Without keeping the precepts? Without chanting, without the full-moon days, without one single good deed? Just by believing, one time?

The room went quiet. Out in the driveway somebody shushed somebody.

Why are you asking me? she said. *Your son already told you.*

When?

Last Tuesday, at the memorial park on Beach Boulevard. You were crying at the wall, and a boy was crying at the end of the row, and you went to him and said, Hey, em, why are you crying, you're young, you have everything. And she told the rest of it, every word, the car and the wheels and the gold and the jade and the chrome and the silver, and the sun and the moon, and who was the crazy one, and the bucket of water, and the five precepts. Lộc had told no one. Not even Thu. He sat on his stool and listened to his own words come out of her mouth, and the tears ran down his face, and he did not wipe them.

It isn't one, and it isn't two, she said, to the room. *It isn't a hundred or a thousand. Nobody can count how many.*

People shifted. Somebody in the back laughed, not unkindly. A woman from the salons said, loud enough, *That's easy to say.*

Sư Cô Tịnh Liên turned her head toward the altar where the photograph was, as if someone had spoken to her from there.

Bảo, she said. *Come here, please.*

• • •

Everyone who was in that house tells it a little differently, and none of them have stopped telling it. They agree that the light came first, the color of the inside of a lemon, and filled the living room so that the paper plates and the folding chairs and the faces all threw shadows backward. They agree that Bảo was standing in front of the altar in his school shirt, and that he was taller than the ceiling and the ceiling was not in the way. Some say he had come in a gold car and some say a gold house and Mr. Huỳnh says it was a lotus as big as a tire, but they agree about the earrings, two gold studs, round and bright, not lumpy at all. He put his palms together and bowed to the Sư Cô, all the way down, and stood up again.

Bảo, she said. *What did you do, when you were here, to get all this?*

Sư Cô, I looked at you one time, he said. *From the cot in the garage. That's all.*

One look?

One look.

The woman from the salons put her hand over her mouth. Old women all over the room began to say the Buddha's name, Nam mô A Di Đà Phật, Nam mô A Di Đà Phật, low, the way the wind goes through a palm tree, and the people out in the driveway pushed in to see, and nobody stopped them.

Sư Cô Tịnh Liên waited until they were quiet. Then she said it to all of them, sitting on the borrowed chair with her hands in her lap, in the plain voice of somebody reading out the time of the next bus.

> *Beings are not born in that Buddha country of the Tathâgata Amitâyus as a reward and result of good works performed in this present life. No, whatever son or daughter of a family shall hear the name of the blessed Amitâyus, the Tathâgata, and having heard it, shall keep it in mind, and with thoughts undisturbed shall keep it in mind for one, two, three, four, five, six or seven nights,—when that son or daughter of a family comes to die, then that Amitâyus, the Tathâgata, surrounded by an assembly of disciples and followed by a host of Bodhisattvas, will stand before them at their hour of death, and they will depart this life with tranquil minds.*
>
> *— Smaller Sukhâvatî-vyûha 10*

When the light went, the boy went with it. Uncle No was sitting on his low stool with his hands open on his knees, looking at nothing, smiling.

VII. Sun and Moon

The side street · afterward

People on the side street said afterward that the money came out of that house the way water comes out of a broken main. The temple got a new roof, and a parking lot that satisfied the city, and a van. The herb shop on Bolsa found an envelope under its door with a note in it, for the next family who cannot pay. The forty-dollar jeweler got forty dollars and did not know what for. At Tết the children on the side street opened their red envelopes and found hundred-dollar bills, so new they crackled, and ran to show their mothers. Nobody called him Chú Không after that, though for a while nobody could think what else to call him.

He kept the gold studs. He did not give those away. He set them on the altar in the living room in front of Bảo's photograph, side by side on a saucer, the two lumpy yellow things he had hammered out on the vise in the garage to save forty dollars.

In the mornings, when he lit the incense before he went to open the salons, the sun came in low through the front window and lay across the

altar, and one of the studs, the bigger one, caught it and burned like a coal. The other one sat just outside the light, in the shadow of the incense bowl, pale and round and plain. He would stand there with the incense in his hands until the smoke reached the ceiling, looking at the two of them, before he went out.

Background

The verse

> *All that we are is the result of what we have thought: it is founded on our thoughts, it is made up of our thoughts. If a man speaks or acts with a pure thought, happiness follows him, like a shadow that never leaves him.*
>
> Dhammapada 2, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin of Sāvatthī is so stingy that people call him Adinnapubbaka, "Never Gave." He beats out a pair of earrings for his only son himself to save a goldsmith's fee, so the boy is known as Maṭṭhakuṇḍalī, "Burnished Earrings." When the son falls ill with jaundice, the father doses him with home remedies rather than pay a physician, and when the boy is dying he lays him out on the terrace so that visitors will not see the wealth inside. The Buddha, passing on his alms round, sends out a ray of light; the boy turns, sees him, and dies with a heart full of faith, and is reborn among the gods. Later he appears to his grieving father at the cremation ground, weeping for a pair of wheels for his golden chariot, and asks for the sun and the moon. The father, shamed out of his grief, takes refuge, invites the Buddha to a meal, and asks whether anyone reaches heaven by faith alone. Read the full commentary story, or a shorter telling of the story of Maṭṭhakuṇḍalī.

Westminster, California

Little Saigon, 2009

After 1975, and above all after the boat exodus that began in 1978, refugees from Vietnam settled in Westminster and Garden Grove, and by the mid-1980s their business district was known as Little Saigon, now the largest concentration of Vietnamese people outside Vietnam. Many first-generation families ran small businesses such as nail salons and restaurants. The boat people often paid for their passage in gold, and many passed through camps like the one on Pulau Bidong in Malaysia. A 1992 study for U.S. law enforcement described home-invasion gangs that chose victims they believed ran businesses and kept their savings at home instead of in banks. Gold passed a thousand dollars an ounce for the first time in March 2008, as the financial crisis began.

About one in twelve Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders lives with chronic hepatitis B, according to the Centers for Disease Control, as many as two in three of them without knowing it, and the group accounts for more than half of all Americans with the infection. In Vietnam, as across East Asia, Pure Land devotion to the Buddha Amitābha is an important part of Buddhist practice. His eighteenth vow promises rebirth in his western paradise, Sukhāvatī, to anyone who sincerely trusts him and calls on him even ten times. The Amitābha Sūtra, or Smaller Sukhāvatīvyūha, describes that land's golden sands and jewel trees and its lotuses as large as chariot wheels. The passages in the story are from F. Max Müller's translations of the two Sukhāvatīvyūha sūtras in the Sacred Books of the East (1894).

After the story of Maṭṭhakuṇḍalī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 2). The original. Scripture from the Larger and Smaller Sukhâvatî-vyûha, tr. F. Max Müller, Sacred Books of the East vol. 49 (1894). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.3

No Winters

> *Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath*
> *— Ephesians 4:26*

Mar a chuala mi e, on the Middle Fork.

I. The Chair

Notch Creek, Middle Fork of the Koyukuk, Alaska Territory · autumn 1922

Murdo Morrison kept the roadhouse at Notch Creek, seventy miles north of the Arctic Circle, and the men on the creeks called him the Precentor. In the church on the North Shore of St. Ann's Bay, in Cape Breton, where he was raised, there was no organ and no hymnbook. There were the psalms of David in Gaelic, and one man who stood under the pulpit and gave out each line for the people to sing after him. Murdo's father had been that man, and Murdo after him for two years, until he went over the Chilkoot in the spring of '98 with a sack of oatmeal and a borrowed sled. He had not sat under a minister since. He kept the psalms. On Sunday nights he sang one at the stove, giving out the line to nobody, and the Swedes and the Irishmen and the one Montenegrin in the room let him get on with it, the way you let a man wind his watch.

He was fifty-four years old and had twenty-four winters in. In that country a man's age was his winters. Summers did not count, because anybody can stand a summer. A man who had seen the ice come and seen it go out again was a sourdough, and a man who had not was a cheechako if he was seventy, and when two teams met on a trail too narrow to pass,

the driver with fewer winters turned out into the deep snow. Nobody had written this down. Nobody needed to.

The roadhouse was a log building forty feet long with a sod roof, a stove made from an oil drum in the middle of the floor, a rack of poles over the stove for drying socks and moccasins, and bunks along the walls. A meal was two dollars and so was a bunk, and a man who had no two dollars ate anyway and paid at cleanup, or didn't. Murdo had one rule he would say out loud. When the door opened, whoever was nearest got up. You took the man's mitts and his robe. You saw his dogs unhitched and fed. You got him water, and gave him your seat, and had his footgear off him and looked at his toes before he could tell you they were fine, because a man in off the trail at forty below is no judge of his own feet.

Beside the stove stood the one real chair in the house. Murdo had built it of birch in the winter of the deep snow and laced a caribou hide across it, and by custom it belonged to the oldest sourdough in the room, whoever that happened to be on a given night. Murdo never sat in it himself.

His cousin Norman Matheson came up on the last horse scow from Bettles in the second week of September, sitting on a crate of evaporated potatoes with a rug over his knees. He was the son of Murdo's father's sister, sixty-seven years old, and stout, so stout that the scow men had trimmed the load around him. In Baddeck he had kept a store and sat as a justice of the peace and been a major in the county militia, and people there had gone on calling him Major after the store failed and after his wife died, until the title was most of what he had left. He wrote to Murdo. Murdo sent the fare.

Nobody on Notch Creek grudged him that. What they noticed was the rest of it. The Major did not cut wood. He had Murdo's good wolf robe on his bunk. He wore a boiled shirt with a collar, and a black broadcloth coat that he brushed every morning until it shone at the elbows like a stovepipe, and he sent his shirts down the creek to Mrs. Ahlquist with instructions about the starch. And from the first night he sat in the birch chair. He lowered himself into it after supper as if it had been freighted in for him, and folded his hands on his vest, and received the room.

Murdo saw it and said nothing. He had learned from dogs that there is no use correcting anything the first week, and then the first week had gone by.

The sun left Notch Creek on the twenty-ninth of November. It did that every year. The camp lay close under a long ridge called the Sawback, on the south side, and from the end of November the sun could not get over it, though at noon it turned the peaks behind the camp pink for an hour, and a man could read a letter by the sky. There was one low place in the Sawback, cut square like a gunsight, that gave the creek its name. On the ninth of January, at a few minutes before one in the afternoon, if the day was clear, the sun stood in that notch for eleven minutes. Every soul on the creek came out to look at it. Then they had a dance.

II. Mail Day

The roadhouse · January 7, 1923

The mail came once a month by dog team, relayed up from Tanana, and in January it came on the seventh, two days ahead of the sun, so that anybody who could travel was at Morrison's already or on the way. Billy Dunne drove the upper end of the contract. He was twenty-six and had nine winters in, having come into the country at seventeen, and he was vain of them the way a boy is vain of his first moustache.

Three sleds came in behind him that afternoon, in the blue dusk that passed for the middle of the day. Tom Skaggs drove the first. He had come over the pass to the Yukon in '86, ten years before anybody heard the word Klondike, and he had thirty-six winters in, and had left the end of his nose and two fingers in the worst of them. Hans Lien had walked off a farm in Goodhue County, Minnesota, at nineteen, and had twenty-five. He carried his mother's blue china cup in his grub box, the one with the chip, and drank from nothing else. On the third sled were Jonas and Mary, Kobuk people, baptized with those names at the mission down at Allakaket. They hunted sheep and caribou for the camp, and nobody tried to count their winters, since their grandparents had wintered on that river before it had a camp on it or a calendar.

Murdo was out at the cache, sawing a frozen moose quarter. The cook was at the dog pots. The only man in the big room was the Major, in the birch chair, in his collar, with his hands folded on his vest and the lamp behind his white head.

They came in out of the dark in a roll of frost smoke, pulling ice from their beards, and saw him. He did not get up. He looked at each of them in turn and inclined his head.

Tom Skaggs had sat in that chair himself on a good many nights. He looked at the stout old man who had it now, and who plainly expected to keep it, and he did the arithmetic the country had taught him. A man Murdo Morrison would put in that chair over Tom Skaggs would have to be somebody. One of the old Hudson's Bay men, maybe, or one who had come up the river with Harper and McQuesten in the seventies, that he had thought were all dead.

Old-timer, Tom said, and took off his cap. *Skaggs. I don't believe I've had the honor.*

The Major inclined his head again.

So they waited on him. It was the natural thing. Tom Skaggs, with his own moccasins frozen to his socks, fetched the old man a mug of tea from the pot and stood holding it until he took it. Jonas brought in an armload of split spruce and built up the stove on the old man's side. Hans Lien, who had some doctoring, saw how the old man's ankles swelled over his shoes, and got down stiffly on one knee on the floor, and asked would he like them rubbed, since it helped the blood when a man had sat long. Mary stood by the door with her mitts still on, nobody having offered to take them. She watched all of it.

The Major did not say yes and did not say no. He let Hans Lien take his foot in his hands.

Billy Dunne had come in with the sack and was sorting at the mail table. He had carried the Major's letters up the river since October, and he watched this with his mouth a little open.

Major, he said. *Tell these men how many winters you've got in.*

The Major looked at him.

None, he said. *I came in September. I was a man of sixty-seven when I came.*

Hans Lien's hands stopped.

None, said Billy. *You old fraud. You think a great deal of yourself. There's thirty-six winters standing in front of you holding your tea, and twenty-five on its knees at your feet, and people by the door with their mitts on who were here before this river had a name in English. You never got up. You never took so much as a robe. They offer to do for you, and you sit there and let them. And look at you. You're not even sorry.* He snapped his fingers under the Major's nose, the way you would to wake a dog.

The Major got up then. He came out of the chair red to the roots of his hair, and he was all at once what he had been in Baddeck on a court day.

Whom did you come here to see?

Murdo, said Billy. *Same as always.*

You came to see my cousin. And you look at me and say, Who is this? I held the Queen's commission. I sat on the bench at Baddeck nineteen years. I'll have your mail contract, boy. I'll have every one of you turned from this door and every door on the river. I'll see the whole breed of you finished.

He went out through the kitchen to find Murdo, and they saw before the door closed that he was crying.

Tom Skaggs put his cap back on. *We'd better go along,* he said. *A man in that state will say anything, and it'll be us he says it about.*

III. The Flour Bin

The kitchen · the same hour

Murdo came in from the cache with frost on his eyebrows and the bucksaw in his hand. He found his cousin sitting on the flour bin with tears running into his collar, and four men and a woman standing along the wall.

Norman. What is it? You're crying.

These people have insulted me.

Where were you sitting?

In the chair. By the stove.

Did you see them come in?

I saw them.

Did you get up?

I did not.

Did you take their mitts from them, or their robes?

No.

Did you see to their dogs? Did you get them water?

No.

Did you bring any of them a seat? Did you look at their feet?

I did not.

Murdo laid the saw on the table.

Norman, every one of those things was yours to do, for every one of them. A man who won't do them has no business in that chair. The fault here is yours and nobody else's. Ask their pardon.

They insulted me, Murdo. That boy snapped his fingers in my face. I'll not ask pardon of the like of them.

Don't be this way. The fault is yours. Ask their pardon.

I will not.

He's a stubborn old man, Murdo, said Tom Skaggs from the wall. He said it without heat.

He is that. And it isn't new.

We can see for ourselves what he is now, Tom said. *What do you mean, it isn't new?*

Sit down, the lot of you. Billy, the mail will keep. I'm going to tell you about a man I met the first winter I was in the country. I've thought about him every day since September.

IV. Potter's Cabin

The lower river · January 1899

THE FIRST WINTER, MURDO SAID, WAS THE WINTER OF THE boats. In the summer of '98 the overflow from the Klondike went up the Koyukuk in little steamboats that drew too much water, and the river dropped and then froze, and there they were. Most of them walked out over the ice before Christmas. The ones who stayed built cabins where the boats had stopped and called them cities.

There was one such place, and he would not say which, up a side river in under the hills, where the sun had been gone for weeks and was owed back at noon on a day in January that every man in camp had marked on the wall. They had chosen a steamboat captain named Rask to be judge for the winter, there being no other law nearer than the Yukon.

The night before the sun was due, a man came in off the hills. He had been eight months up a creek by himself and had come down for salt and matches. He was a big man, heavy, with his hair grown past his shoulders the way it will in eight months, and he was known as a hard one to share a tent with. He asked two boys at the edge of camp where a traveler could sleep. They sent him to a trader named Potter, who had a storehouse cabin, a large one, that stood empty at night. Potter told him he was welcome to it.

He had hardly got his robe spread when a second man came in off the hills by another trail. This one was young, from the North Shore of St. Ann's, and had been out since spring as well. Potter thought, the first one may not care for company, and I won't answer for it. So he said, *There's a man in there ahead of you. If he's willing, it's all one to me.* The young man went to the door and asked. *Friend, if it's no trouble to you, I'd be glad of the floor for one night.* And the big man said, *It's a big cabin. Come in and lie over on that side.* They spoke civilly enough, and shared out what they had.

When it came time to sleep, the young man took note of where the other lay and where the door was, so that he could find his way out in the night without striking a light. But the big man, when he lay down, did not lie where he had been sitting. He dragged his robe over and lay down square across the doorway.

In the night the young man had to go out. He felt his way along the wall to the door and stepped, and his foot came down on the big man's hair.

Who's that treading on my hair?

It's me, friend.

You come down out of the hills like a tramp and walk on a man's head.

I didn't know you were lying there. I'm sorry for it. He went out, and behind him he could hear the big man crying with rage, like a child.

The big man thought, he'll walk on me coming in, too. Let him. He turned himself end for end and lay with his head where his feet had been. And the young man, coming back, thought, I hurt him the last time, I'll go in past his feet. He stepped wide to the other side, and his foot came down on the big man's neck.

Who is that?

It's me.

First my hair and now my neck. I'll put a curse on you.

Friend, I meant you no harm. I didn't know you had turned. I came in this side to keep off you. Forgive me.

I'll curse you.

Don't do that.

The big man would hear nothing. He said it.

Tomorrow when the sun comes back over the hill, may your head split in seven pieces.

Now the young man had a temper of his own in those days, Murdo said. He answered, *I told you it was no fault of mine, and you have cursed me all the same. Then let it fall on the one who is at fault and leave the other alone.* And he said the same words back. *Tomorrow when the sun comes back over the hill, may your head split in seven pieces.*

His grandmother on the North Shore had the two sights, and some of it had come down to him, though he had never asked for it. The words were hardly out when he saw where they would land. He saw the big man standing in the snow at noon with the sun on his face, and he saw what happened to his head. He was sorry then. He went out on the river ice in the dark and stood facing south, and asked that the sun be kept back.

He never told anyone what words he used. But the sun did not come.

V. The Pool

The same camp · the next day

NOON CAME. THE WHOLE CAMP STOOD OUT ON THE ICE IN whatever it had that was clean, looking at the hill, and the sky behind the hill never so much as turned yellow. They waited an hour. Then they went

IN A BODY TO CAPTAIN RASK'S CABIN, EIGHTY MEN, AND STOOD in front of his door and set up a noise.

Captain, the sun hasn't come back, and you're the judge here. Make it come up for us.

Rask was a fair man. He went back over the winter in his own mind, what he had ruled and said and thought, the claims, the split of the flour, and he could find nothing crooked in it. Then he thought, there is a quarrel in this camp that I don't know about. *Has anybody come in lately?*

Two men last night, Captain, off the hills. They're in Potter's cabin.

He went there with men carrying lanterns ahead of him at one o'clock in the afternoon, and found the two of them sitting against opposite walls. He took off his cap to the young one and sat down on a crate.

A man can't see to work, Rask said. *He can't see to cut his wood. I'm asking you. Why has it gone dark on us?*

The young man told him all of it. *He cursed me, and I cursed him back. I said, let it fall on whichever of us is to blame. Then I looked to see where it would fall, and I saw that the minute the sun touched him, his head would go in seven pieces. I didn't want that. So I'm keeping it back.*

How does he get clear of it?

He asks my pardon. That's all.

Then ask it, said Rask to the big man.

This tramp stood on my hair and he stood on my neck. I'll not ask his pardon.

Ask it, man. Don't be like this.

I will not.

Your head will split.

Let it. I will not ask his pardon.

No, said Rask. *I can see you won't. Not if it's left to you.*

He called four men in. They took the big man by the wrists and the ankles and the belt and the back of the neck and carried him across the floor, and bent him down until his forehead rested on the young man's moccasins.

Get up, friend, the young man said. *I forgive you.*

But to Rask he said, *He didn't ask it of his own will, so it isn't finished. There's the warm spring above the camp, where the pool stays open. Take him there. Put a lump of clay from the bank on the top of his head, and stand him in the water up to his neck.*

They did that. The clay at that spring is blue, and it froze on his head like a cap. The young man came and stood on the bank in the steam.

Friend, I'm going to let the sun come now. The moment it does, go under. Come up somewhere else, and go where you like.

The sun came over the hill a day late, at five minutes past one. The first of it struck across the pool and touched the lump of clay, and the clay cracked into seven pieces and fell in the water. The big man went under. He came up on the far side in the steam, where somebody had left a parka, and he was seen running down the river trail with it on, and nobody on the Koyukuk laid eyes on him again.

Some of the men from that camp are still in the country. They don't agree about much. They agree that the sun was a day late in '99.

VI. The Notch

Notch Creek · January 7 to 9, 1923

THE KITCHEN WAS QUIET. THE COOK HAD COME TO THE DOOR with the dog ladle in his hand and stayed there.

Who was the young one? said Billy Dunne.

A boy off the North Shore with more temper than sense. He has kept a roadhouse since. Rask died at Nome. The big man I never learned the name of. Murdo looked at his cousin. *But I knew him, Norman, when you came off the scow. I knew the way he lay down.*

Then he spoke to his cousin and to nobody else, though the rest of them heard it.

A man who goes on telling it over to himself, they insulted me, they laid hands on me, they got the better of me, they took what was mine, that man's quarrel never gets done. It will be with him in the ground. And the man who leaves off telling it over, his gets done. That's the whole of it, Norman. There is a

text you know as well as I do. It was written for a country where the sun goes down every night.

> *Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath*
>
> *— Ephesians 4:26*

Up here it has been down since November. A man can keep his wrath a long while on this creek.

It was a Sunday. He sang then, standing by the flour bin with his cap in his hand, the way he had stood under the pulpit on the North Shore. He gave it in the English of the Scottish book so the room would have it. He gave out each line and waited, as if for the people to sing it after him, and the second time he waited, Hans Lien, who had been raised on other tunes entirely, hummed it back.

> *Do thou from anger cease, and wrath*
> *see thou forsake also:*
> *Fret not thyself in any wise,*
> *that evil thou should'st do.*
>
> *— Psalm 37:8, Scottish Psalter (1650)*

The Major sat on the flour bin with his hands on his knees. He asked nobody's pardon. Tom Skaggs, who had expected nothing else, went back into the big room and sat down on a bench, and after a minute Murdo went in and moved him to the birch chair.

• • •

The ninth was clear, and fifty-one below. A little after noon they all went out and stood in the creek bed facing the Sawback, some forty people, with their breath going straight up. Billy Dunne held Murdo's watch. The sky in the notch went from green to brass. At eleven minutes to one a point of light too bright to look at stood in the bottom of the gunsight, and their shadows fell out behind them on the snow, long and blue, the

first shadows any of them had cast in six weeks. Nobody cheered. Mary laughed out loud, once. Tom Skaggs took off his cap to it.

The Major had come out last and stood apart, at the corner of the roadhouse, in his sealskin cap. When the light reached him, a few of them saw him put his hand up to the crown of his head and hold it there. Then the sun went behind the ridge, eleven minutes after it had come. The cold shut down again, and they went in to get ready for the dance.

Late that night a cousin of Jonas's came in off the upriver trail, forty miles since morning, a man nobody had expected, with his eyelashes frozen together. The door opened on the fiddle and the frost smoke rolled across the floor. Murdo was at the far end of the room with a tray. Billy Dunne was dancing with Mrs. Ahlquist.

The Major was nearest. He was sitting on the bench by the door, because Tom Skaggs had the chair. He looked at the man in the doorway. He looked down the room at his cousin, who was not looking at him.

Then he got up. It took him some time. He said nothing to the man, no welcome and no word about the cold. He took the mitts off the man's hands, one and then the other, and carried them across to the stove, and hung them on the drying pole with the palms turned to the heat, the way he had seen it done.

Background

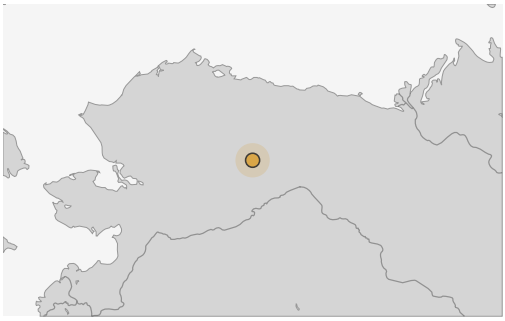
The verses

> *"He abused me, he beat me, he defeated me, he robbed me,"--in those who harbour such thoughts hatred will never cease.*
>
> Dhammapada 3, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *"He abused me, he beat me, he defeated me, he robbed me,"--in those who do not harbour such thoughts hatred will cease.*
>
> Dhammapada 4, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Tissa is the Buddha's older cousin, his father's sister's son, who becomes a monk as a fat old man and takes to sitting in the middle of the monastery hall in well-pressed robes. Visiting monks mistake him for a great elder and offer to wait on him. When a young monk learns that he has not kept a single rains retreat,

which is how monks count seniority, he rebukes him and snaps his fingers. Tissa goes weeping to the Buddha, who asks whether he rose, took the visitors' things, brought water or seats, or rubbed their feet, and then tells him to ask their pardon. He refuses. The Buddha then tells of the ascetic Devala, who lay down across a doorway, was stepped on twice by the ascetic Nārada, and cursed him: at sunrise his head should split in seven. Nārada, seeing that the curse would fall on Devala himself, kept the sun from rising until the king forced Devala to bow, and then saved him with a lump of clay and a pond. Read the full commentary story.



Koyukuk River, Alaska Territory

The upper Koyukuk, *1923*

The Koyukuk drains the south slope of the Brooks Range, north of the Arctic Circle. In the summer of 1898, overflow from the Klondike rush went up it by steamboat; one stampeder later remembered sixty-eight small steamers frozen in that autumn with nine hundred people aboard, most of whom walked out over the ice (the account is quoted in the National Park Service history of the region, *Gaunt Beauty, Tenuous Life*). The camps that lasted were far upriver at Coldfoot and Wiseman, supplied by horse-drawn scows from Bettles in summer and by a monthly dog-team mail in winter. By the early 1920s only about a hundred white miners remained, living beside Koyukon Athabascan and Kobuk Iñupiaq families, many of whom had ties to the Episcopal mission of St. John's-in-the-Wilderness at Allakaket. The forester Robert Marshall described the district a few years later in *Arctic Village*. A later chapter of the same history covers the 1920s. Notch Creek, its roadhouse and its ridge are invented. In a camp under a ridge at that latitude the sun stays hidden for weeks in midwinter, and its return was the great day of the year. A newcomer, or cheechako, became a sourdough by staying through a winter.

Many of the Gaelic-speaking Presbyterians of Cape Breton came from the Highlands and Hebrides in the early nineteenth century and kept the old way of singing the metrical psalms without instruments, a precentor giving out each line and the congregation singing it back, a practice called lining out. The psalm Murdo sings is

from the Scottish Psalter of 1650, the English metrical version approved by the Church of Scotland and still in use. The verse from Ephesians is given in the King James Version.

After the story of the Elder Thulla Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 3 and 4). The original. Scripture from the Scottish Metrical Psalter (1650) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

1.4

Dinner on the Ground

Hatred stirreth up strifes: but love covereth all sins.
— Proverbs 10:12

Now the way I heard it, on the Little Buffalo.

I. Hagar

Newton County, Arkansas · 1886–1892

Jesse Coffey's daddy died when Jesse was fifteen, and after that Jesse did it all himself, the plowing and the fence and the stock and the wood, on forty acres of rocky bottom and steep ridge where Cutter Branch comes into the Little Buffalo. He kept his mother too. She had the rheumatism and could not do much but sit on the porch and shell beans and watch him work.

Son, let me go fetch you a wife.

I don't want a wife, Mama. I want to see after you as long as you live.

You're doing the field work and the house work both, and it ain't right, and I won't have it. Let me fetch you a girl.

He said no, and no, and then he quit saying anything. When she put on her bonnet to go up the creek to the Villines place, where there were four grown girls, he asked her where she was going, and when she told him, he said not there, and told her about a family down at the Gap he liked better. So she went where he wanted, and came back with Ada Treat, who was eighteen and red-headed and could outwork any two men on the creek. They were married at the Gap in the fall of 1886.

Ada had no children. One year. Three years. Five.

You picked her yourself, his mother said at last, *and she's barren as a rock. A man with no young'uns, when he dies the place goes to the cousins and the name goes in the ground with him. Let me go fetch you another one.*

Hush, Mama.

But she would not hush, and Ada heard it through the board wall, night after night, lying in the dark beside him. She lay there and thought it through. A son don't cross his mama, not on this creek. If the old woman goes out and fetches some girl, and the girl has a baby, I'll be the hired girl in my own kitchen till I die. Then she thought: suppose I fetch one myself.

She knew her Bible. She knew where Sarai said to Abram, and she went and found it to be sure.

> *And Sarai said unto Abram, Behold now, the LORD hath restrained me from bearing: I pray thee, go in unto my maid; it may be that I may obtain children by her. And Abram hearkened to the voice of Sarai.*
>
> *— Genesis 16:2*

She went up the hollow to the Sizemores, who were the poorest people on Cutter Branch and had a girl named Lettie, sixteen, who was quick and quiet and pretty. The Sizemores ran her off the porch the first time. *Woman, what are you saying to us?* She came back the next week and the week after. She said she was barren, and a place with no children dies out, and if Lettie gave Jesse a son, Lettie's boy would have the forty acres and Lettie would have the say of the house, and the Sizemores would never be hungry again. In the end, because they were hungry, they let her take the girl.

There was no preacher and no paper. Everybody on the creek knew what it was, and some of them said so, and the Coffeys did not go to meeting after that. But nobody's business is anybody's business in a hollow, and in a year people mostly quit talking.

II. Pennyroyal

Cutter Branch · 1892–1894

As soon as Lettie was in the house Ada thought: if she has a baby, it's her house. That's just how it'll be. I can't let her have one.

Honey, she told Lettie, *the minute you think you're carrying, you tell me first. I'll see you through it.*

Lettie said she would, and when it happened she did. Every evening Ada fixed her a cup of sassafras tea with her own hands, and that night she put pennyroyal in it, a good handful, steeped strong. Lettie lost the baby before the month was out. In the spring Lettie told her again, and Ada fixed the tea, and Lettie lost that one too.

That summer at a quilting at the Villines place, with Ada not there, the women sat around the frame and asked Lettie about it, and she told them, and they looked at one another across the quilt.

Child, you're a fool. Who do you reckon fixes your tea? That woman is afraid you'll get the upper hand. She's putting something in it. Next time you don't tell her nothing.

So the third time Lettie said nothing. But in the fifth month Ada saw her bending over the washpot in the yard, and saw the shape of her.

Why didn't you tell me you was carrying?

You brought me down here, Lettie said, *and twice you've made me lose my babies. Why would I tell you?*

Ada went in the house and stood by the stove. Now I'm done for, she thought. And after that she watched. She watched all summer and into the fall, and in November, when Lettie was near her time and down sick with a cold, Ada fixed her a cup of tea with whiskey and honey in it for the cough, and a double handful of the other thing.

It was too late for the tea to do what it did before. The baby was too far along. What it did instead was bring her to labor, wrong, with the baby lying crossways in her and no way out. The granny woman from the Gap came at midnight and worked till dawn and could not turn it, and went out on the porch and told Jesse there was nothing she could do.

Lettie knew. She raised up on the pillow and looked at Ada standing at the foot of the bed.

You killed me, she said. *You fetched me down here, you, nobody else, and you killed my three young'uns, and now you've killed me. I'm going. And when I'm gone I'll come back. I don't care what I come back as. I'll come back and get yours.*

She died before noon with the baby in her.

Jesse took hold of Ada in the kitchen. *You've done for my whole family,* he said, and he beat her with his fists and his knees and a stick of stovewood until the old woman got up off the porch and came in and stopped him. Ada lay in the back room all December. She died on Christmas Eve, of what he had done to her, though the doctor who came out from Jasper wrote down pneumonia. Jesse sold the stock in the spring and went off to the zinc mines in Missouri and was not seen on the creek again.

III. The Cat and the Hen

Cutter Branch · 1895–1910

The house on Cutter Branch stood empty after that, with the door open and the old woman's rocker still on the porch. Nobody would live in it. People said things about it, the way people do.

What the old women on the creek said was this. That the spring after the funerals, a yellow cat took up in the Coffey house, a thin one with a torn ear that nobody had ever seen before. And a red hen that had gone wild when the stock was sold was still laying in the loft. And the cat found the hen's nest and ate the eggs. And the hen laid again, and the cat ate them again. Three times. They said that the third time the hen stood in the loft door with her feathers all out and made a sound no hen makes, and then she went at the cat, and the cat killed her. And they said if you had been there and heard it, you would know who those two were.

They said more. That a few years after, a painter came down out of the bluffs above the Little Buffalo, a she-painter, the last one anybody in Newton County ever saw, and every spring for three springs she took the fawns from one doe that came down to drink at the mouth of Cutter

Branch. They said the doe stood on the gravel bar and bleated for them, three springs running, so you could hear it a mile. They said that in the fall of 1910 a man from Jasper killed the painter on the bluff, and the same week the storekeeper's wife at the Gap was brought to bed of a girl, and they named her Opal. And that the next fall a boy shot that old doe in the bottom, and that was the fall the woman named Dorcas came walking down the creek road with nothing in her hands and nobody belonging to her.

That is what the old women said. The preachers said it was foolishness, and the old women said yes, it surely was, and went on saying it.

IV. The Cradle

Shiloh Gap · 1928–1931

Dorcas lived wherever somebody would let her, in a smokehouse, in a corn crib, in the loft of the church house one winter till the deacons found out. She did washing and hoed corn for whoever would pay her in meal. She was dark and thin and nobody could guess how old she was. Dorcas is a Bible name. It means a deer.

She and Opal had been thick as thieves since they were girls. Opal was the storekeeper's daughter, with shoes in winter, and Dorcas was nobody's, and they had sat together on the store porch with their feet hanging off and talked the way girls do. When Opal married Clell Henson in 1928 and went to live at the mouth of the hollow, where the mail road comes in off the ridge, Dorcas was the first one to walk out and see the new house.

The baby came the next fall, a boy. Dorcas walked out to see it.

Where's Opal at?

In the back room, Clell's mother said. *She just had the baby.*

Boy or girl? Let me look at it.

She went in and bent over the cradle, close, the way women do, and nobody thought a thing about it. She stayed a while and then she went home. In the morning the baby was dead in the cradle with not a mark on him. People on the creek said what they said, that she had bent down

over him and drawn out his breath, the way a cat will do a baby if you leave it, and that was why she had been so close. Opal did not believe it. Nobody could make her believe it.

The second one came in the summer of 1930, the summer the rain quit. It did not rain in June and it did not rain in July. The Little Buffalo went down to a string of green holes. The corn burned in the field before it tasseled and the gardens dried up and blew away. Dorcas walked out to see the baby, and bent over the cradle, and in the morning that one was dead too.

That was the winter everybody went hungry. People ate poke and wild onions and squirrel and whatever else there was. Down at England, in Lonoke County, hundreds of farmers came into town and stood in the street and told the merchants they would have food for their children or know why. The Red Cross came into Newton County with flour and lard and slips of paper you had to fill out. Dorcas did not fill out the slips of paper. She looked at Opal's mother's shelves in the store at the Gap the way a dog looks at a door.

In the spring Opal was carrying again. She went to Clell.

Something out here has killed two of my babies, she said. *I don't care what it is. I don't care what anybody says it is. This one I'm going to have at Mama's.*

It happened that in May Dorcas had gone off with a truckload of pickers out of Jasper, following the crops, berries and then beans and then peaches, the way hill people did that year to get a little money, and she was gone four months. Some of that crew did not come back. It was a hot summer. Opal went to her mother's at the store in June, and had the baby there in July, a boy, and lived.

V. The Baptizing Hole

Shiloh Gap · August, 1931

Dorcas came back in the middle of August with what she had on and walked straight out to the Henson place at the mouth of the hollow.

Where's Opal at?

Clell's mother stood in the door. *Where you won't get at her. Something's been coming in this house and killing her babies, and she's gone to her mama's to have this one.*

She can go where she likes, Dorcas said. *She won't get away from me.* And she turned around and started for the Gap, walking fast in the heat, and Clell's mother said afterward that the dog would not go out from under the porch for an hour.

• • •

There was a revival on at the Gap that week, a brush arbor on the flat by the creek, cedar posts with oak boughs laid across the top for shade and split-log benches under, and lanterns hung on nails at night. The preacher was a Pentecostal girl from over in Missouri named Velma Gentry. She was nineteen years old and had been preaching since she was fourteen. She wore a plain white dress and no jewelry and no paint, and she did not holler, and she did not dance on the benches, and people came from three counties anyhow, in wagons and on foot and in a Model T or two, to sit under the arbor in the heat and listen to her. Her brother Ancel drove her from meeting to meeting in an old truck and led the singing with a guitar, and slept in the truck bed, and saw to everything else.

On the Sunday afternoon Opal and Clell carried the baby up to the arbor and Sister Velma took him in her arms and dedicated him to the Lord in front of everybody, and they named him out loud, Jesse, after nobody in particular, because Opal liked it. Then they started home down the creek path with the baby, because Opal said she would not hide at her mother's forever.

Below the arbor the creek bent around a rock ledge and made a deep green hole where they did the baptizing. It was very hot. Opal handed the baby to Clell and waded into the baptizing hole in her slip and ducked under and came up and sat on the ledge in the shade. Then Clell went in, and Opal sat on the rock with her wet hair down her back and nursed the baby.

She looked up, and Dorcas was coming down the creek path.

Clell! Clell! Come quick! Come quick! It's her!

She did not wait for him. She got up with the baby and ran, barefoot, in her wet slip, back up the path and up the bank and in under the brush arbor, where Sister Velma was standing at the front under the lanterns talking to sixty or seventy people who had stayed for the evening meeting. Opal ran straight down the aisle between the split-log benches and fell on her knees on the sawdust and laid the baby down at the girl preacher's feet.

Here. I give him to you. He's yours. Just let him live.

Sumner Daves was standing at the back of the arbor where he always stood at revivals, a blacksmith as wide as a door, to keep the drunks from coming in off the road. He saw Dorcas come up the bank, and something in her face made him step out into the opening and put his arm across it, and he would not let her by.

Sister Velma looked down at the baby on the sawdust, and up at the opening.

Ancel, she said. *Go bring that woman in here.*

Ancel went down the aisle and spoke to Sumner Daves, and Sumner took his arm down, and Ancel brought Dorcas in.

Here she comes, Opal said, on her knees, without looking around. *Here she comes.*

Let her come, said Sister Velma. *Hush, now.*

Dorcas came down the aisle and stood in front of her. The arbor was so quiet you could hear the creek.

Why have you done this? Sister Velma said to her. Her voice was not loud. *Why do you keep doing it? You two have been at it since before either one of you was born. If you hadn't walked in here tonight you'd have gone on till Judgment, the cat and the hen, the painter and the doe, one of you and then the other, taking the young'uns and taking the young'uns. Every one of you saying, she done it to me, I'll do it to her. It don't stop that way. It never has stopped that way, not once since the world was made. Listen at me.*

Say not, I will do so to him as he hath done to me: I will render to the man according to his work.

Hatred stirreth up strifes: but love covereth all sins.

— Proverbs 24:29; 10:12

Dorcas stood in front of the girl preacher with her hands hanging at her sides. Nobody in the arbor could see her face but Sister Velma. Whatever Sister Velma saw in it, she nodded, once, as if somebody had told her the answer to a question.

VI. Bread

The same night

Opal, Sister Velma said. *Pick up your baby and give him to her.*

Opal looked up from the sawdust. *I'm scared to.*

I know it. Don't be. You've got nothing to be scared of from her now.

Opal picked up the baby off the sawdust and stood up in her wet slip, shaking, and held him out, and Dorcas took him.

She held him a long time. She put her face down against his head and smelled of it, the way women do. She kissed him on the forehead and on both his hands. Then she gave him back to his mother, carefully, the way you hand somebody something that might spill, and stood there in front of everybody and began to cry.

What are you crying for? Sister Velma said.

I never had enough to eat, Dorcas said. *Not one day of my life. I've always got by somehow, but I never had enough. Not once. And now I don't know how I'm going to live.*

Sister Velma looked at her a while. Then she turned to Opal.

Take her home with you. Let her live in your house. Feed her the best you've got.

> *If thine enemy be hungry, give him bread to eat; and if he be thirsty, give him water to drink: For thou shalt heap coals of fire upon his head, and the LORD shall reward thee.*
>
> *— Proverbs 25:21–22*

Then Ancel struck up the guitar, because he did not know what else to do, and after a minute people began to sing.

VII. Wet Year, Dry Year

Cutter Branch · 1931–1934

Opal took her home and made her a pallet in the loft over the front room and fed her the best they had, which that year was cornbread and sorghum and a little side meat, and buttermilk when the cow was fresh.

But in September Clell started knocking corn off the cob for meal on the porch below the loft, with a stick of hickory, and every time the stick came down Dorcas sat straight up on her pallet.

I can't stay up here. It sounds like it's coming down on my head. Put me somewhere else.

So Opal put her in the crib by the meal grinder, and then in the springhouse, and then in the kitchen lean-to, and then in the cellar, and then in the shed by the ash hopper, and then in the little house by the mail road gate. And Dorcas would not stay in any of them. *The grinder sounds like it's grinding me. The boys come and empty the slop buckets right by the door. The dogs lay up against the wall all night. The boys use that side of it for a toilet. Your mama-in-law throws the sweepings right there. And the big boys sit on the gate and tell fortunes with a broom straw and a Bible and holler.*

At last Clell said there was nobody living in the old Coffey house up at the head of Cutter Branch. It had stood empty for thirty-seven years. He and two Villines boys went up and put a new roof on it and a door that shut, and carried up a bedstead, and Dorcas went up there by herself and lived in it. Every morning Opal or the boy carried up a covered dish with the best of whatever they had.

• • •

In the spring of 1932 Dorcas said to Opal, *It's going to be wet this year. Don't plant nothing in the bottom. Plant your corn up on the ridge.*

Clell laughed. Nobody on the Little Buffalo plants on the ridge if he has bottom ground. But Opal made him, and that June it rained for nine days without stopping, and Cutter Branch came up over the bottoms from hill to hill and took every row of corn on the creek and laid it down in the mud. Up on the ridge, Clell's corn stood up green and dry.

The year after that she said nothing, because it was an ordinary year, and in the spring of 1934 she said, *Dry this year. Plant the bottoms. Right down by the water.* And that summer the ridges burned up and the bottoms by the creek, where the ground held the damp, made a crop.

People came to Opal. *How did you know? Wet or dry, your corn comes in every year, and ours burns or drowns. Who's telling you?*

Dorcas, Opal said. *Up at the old Coffey place. She tells me wet or dry, and I plant high or low according. Don't you see me carry the dish up there every morning? That's where it goes. You carry her something too, and she'll tell you.*

So they did. They carried up cornbread and beans and fried pies and jars of kraut and whatever there was, and Dorcas sat on the old Coffey porch in the old woman's rocker and looked at the sky over the bluffs and told them, high ground or low, and she was never wrong. She put on flesh. She lived to be very old. She was the one who told the people at the Gap that there ought to be eight families to take the dinner up to her, turn and turn about, and that on Decoration Day, when the whole Gap spreads the dinner on the ground under the cedars at the cemetery, the first plate ought to be fixed before the blessing and carried up the hollow.

They still do it. Dorcas has been gone a long time now, and the old Coffey house fell in years ago and there is nothing at the head of Cutter Branch but a chimney and a walnut tree. But every Decoration Day at Shiloh Gap, when the boards are laid across the sawhorses and the women uncover the dishes, somebody fixes a plate first, chicken and dumplings and deviled eggs and a piece of every pie, and covers it with a clean dish towel, and one of the children carries it up the hollow in both hands

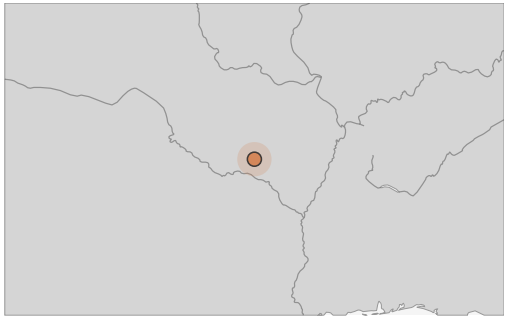
and sets it on the chimney rock, and comes back, and then they say the blessing.

Background

The verse

> *For hatred does not cease by hatred at any time: hatred ceases by love, this is an old rule.*
>
> Dhammapada 5, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a barren wife, afraid that a fertile second wife will make her a servant in her own house, chooses the second wife herself, then secretly gives her drugs that make her miscarry, twice. The third time the child lodges crosswise and the young wife dies cursing her, vowing to come back and devour her children, and the husband beats the barren wife to death. The two are reborn in the same house as a cat and a hen, and then as a leopardess and a doe, and in each life one eats the other's young and vows revenge. At last one is born a woman of Sāvatthī and the other a *yakkhinī*, an ogress, who comes as a friend and devours two of her babies. With the third, the mother flees into the monastery and lays the child at the Buddha's feet. The Buddha has the ogress brought in, tells them that hatred is never ended by hatred, and has the mother hand her the child. The ogress kisses it and weeps because she has never had enough to eat; the mother takes her home, tries lodging her in one place after another, and settles her outside the village, where she tells the farmers whether the year will be wet or dry and is fed by all of them. Read the full commentary story, or a shorter telling of the story of the ogress Kāḷi.



Newton County, Arkansas

The Arkansas Ozarks, 1930–1934

In the drought of 1930, June and July were the driest Arkansas had recorded, Little Rock went seventy-one days without rain, and August temperatures reached 113 degrees. Between a third and a half of the state's crops were lost, and by November outbreaks of pellagra and typhoid were being blamed on it. When the Red Cross opened its food program in January 1931, more than 165,000 people signed up in three days. On January 3, a few hundred farmers gathered in the town of England, in Lonoke County, and demanded food for their hungry neighbors; local merchants handed it out, and the England food riot made national news.

The Assemblies of God was founded at Hot Springs, Arkansas, in 1914, and from its first year it gave credentials to women as evangelists, though not as pastors until 1935; by the fall of 1914, 142 of its 512 credential holders were women missionaries or evangelists. Country revivals were often held under a brush arbor, poles driven into the ground with cut branches laid across the top, put up when a traveling preacher sent word ahead. Decoration Day, when families clean the graves of a country cemetery and spread a dinner on the ground, is kept on a Sunday each spring or summer throughout the Upland South, including Arkansas and southern Missouri.

After the story of the Yakkhinī Kāḷi from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 5). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.5

The Washing Cup

> *For we must needs die, and are as water spilt on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again*
> *— 2 Samuel 14:14*

Azoy hob ikh gehert, on Sheldrake Hill.

I. The Cup

Sheldrake Hill, Sullivan County, New York · autumn 1905

Fourteen Jewish families farmed the stony side of Sheldrake Hill above Centreville Station, on land the Yankees had given up on. The Society in New York had lent them the money to buy it. They kept a few cows each and shipped the milk down to the creamery by the depot, where it went into the cans on the Ontario and Western and was in the city by morning. In summer they took boarders, garment workers and their wives who came up on the train for two weeks of air, and sometimes a young man with a cough who had been sent up from the East Side because the big hotels at Liberty advertised in the newspapers, *No Hebrews or Consumptives.* In winter there was nothing but cows and snow and Torah.

Their prayer house had been a wagon shed. It had a stove, an ark built by a cabinetmaker from Minsk out of pine boards, and behind it a privy, and in the privy a tin basin and a two-handled washing cup, so that a man could wash his hands before he went back in to stand before God.

Two learned men lived on the hill, and each of them had his following. Feivel Melnik was the melamed. He taught the boys their Hebrew in his kitchen through the winter, and on Sabbath afternoons he preached, and when he preached the boarders sat on the benches in their city clothes

and wept, and the young men who worked winters in the shops on Hester Street said there was nobody in New York to touch him. Hirsh Kagan was the shochet. He slaughtered for the whole hill, chickens on Thursdays and a calf when there was a calf, and he knew the law of every knife and every knot. Feivel knew what the law was for. Hirsh knew what it said.

One morning in the month of Cheshvan, after the holidays, Feivel went out to the privy, and washed his hands, and came back in, and left the water standing in the basin.

Hirsh went out after him and saw it. When he came back in he waited until the end of the prayers and then took Feivel by the sleeve.

Reb Feivel, was it you that left the water?

Yes.

You don't know that it's forbidden? That water has to be poured out right away, where people don't walk.

I didn't know.

Well, it's forbidden.

Then I'll make it right, said Feivel, and he was already turning to go and pour it out when Hirsh put a hand on his arm.

If you didn't know, it's nothing, Hirsh said. *Leave it.*

So Feivel left it, and thought no more about it.

But that week Hirsh said to the men who came to him with their chickens, *Our melamed breaks the law and doesn't know it when he does.* And the men who came with chickens said it to the men who sent their boys to Feivel. *Your teacher breaks the law and doesn't know it.* And the fathers of the boys told Feivel. Feivel put down his book.

On Monday he said it was nothing. Now it's a sin. He's a liar.

And that went back up the road too.

By Chanukah Hirsh Kagan and the men on his side had declared that Feivel Melnik could not be counted in a minyan or called up to the Torah until he acknowledged his transgression, and Feivel's side had declared that a shochet who passed judgment on a scholar over a basin of dirty water was no judge, and they took their prayers to the dining room of Gitl Rapoport's boarding house, which stood empty in winter, and set a bookcase where the ark should be. Two minyanim on a hill that could

barely make one. Husbands went one way and wives' brothers the other. The milk wagons stopped going down together. At the creamery the Sheldrake men stood in two lines on the platform and would not hand one another a can. The Society in New York received two letters about the same basin of water, in Yiddish, each eleven pages long.

The old women said it went higher than that. They said that in the little burying ground on the ridge, where nine of their dead were lying under the hemlocks, the dead had taken sides too, and that if you went up there at night you could hear them at it.

II. The Old Man

The upper farm · December

Reb Ezra Lifshitz had been the rav of a town of four thousand Jews in Volhynia, and now he kept six cows on the last farm at the top of the road, where the fields gave out into woods. He was seventy-one. He had buried a wife there and a daughter in Brooklyn. Both of the learned men had been his pupils. When the colony first came up to the hill it was Reb Ezra they had followed, and he still came down for the Sabbath in a long coat gone green at the seams, walking, with his stick.

His grandson Leybl, who was nineteen and hauled the milk, carried word down the hill. *The Rov says, be one congregation.* He came back up. *They say they can't.*

The second time the same.

The third time Reb Ezra put on his coat and said, *The congregation is torn. The congregation is torn,* and walked down in the snow.

He stood in the wagon shed with both of them in front of him and told Hirsh his wrong, which was that he had passed a sentence over a cup of water against a man he had already forgiven. He told Feivel his wrong, which was that he would not see a fault because it was Hirsh who had found it. He told them both to pray under one roof. Where they could not stand to sit together at a table, he said, let them sit at separate tables, but in one room.

It held for a week and a half. Then it broke again, over who would read the portion. Reb Ezra came down again.

Enough. No more of this. And because the hill was full of boys who had heard the story from him a hundred times, he told it again. A flock of quail lived in a field where a fowler set his net every morning, and every morning they lifted the net together, all of them at once, and flew off with it and dropped it in a thornbush, and the fowler went home with nothing. Then one morning in landing one quail stepped on another's head, and the other said, *Who stepped on me?* and the first said, *I didn't step on anybody,* and the next morning when the net came down each was waiting for the other to lift it. The fowler went home with a full sack.

They listened, and nodded, and a young man from Feivel's side named Mottel Gross stood up near the stove.

Rebbe, with respect. Go home to your cows. Let it alone. We'll make our own shame without you.

Reb Ezra looked at him a while. Then he told them another story, from the old country, from the days of the Polish lords.

There were two inns on a river, he said, an upper inn and a lower, and both were leased from the count by Jews. The man at the lower inn, Zalman, was rich and wanted both. He went to the count's steward with a purse and took the lease of the upper inn out from under Reb Dovid, who had kept it thirty years, and Reb Dovid and his wife went off with their little boy and lived in a village two days away, where Reb Dovid sold needles from a box and nobody knew who he had been. Years later Zalman heard where he was, and went to the steward again, and said Reb Dovid was a thief who owed the count a year's rent. The count's men took Reb Dovid and his wife and hanged them in the marketplace of the town. Their son was grown by then. He stood in the crowd. His father saw him there and said, loud enough for him to hear and nobody else to understand, *Not long, Yankel. Not short.*

Yankel went and hired himself to Zalman as a coachman, under another name. He was a good coachman. Zalman came to trust him above everybody. One winter they were driving home through the forest at night, and the horses were tired, and Zalman lay down in the sleigh with

his head on Yankel's knee and slept. Yankel took out his knife. Three times he took it out, and three times he heard his father, *Not long, not short,* and put it back. Then Zalman woke up shaking and said he had dreamed that Dovid's son had come for him with a knife.

I am Dovid's son, said Yankel. And he told him. And they made their peace in the sleigh, in the forest, in the snow.

That was a Jew who had a reason, said Reb Ezra. *You have a basin of water.*

It did no good. That night Feivel's people went back to the dining room at Gitl Rapoport's.

III. The Road Up

After Chanukah · winter 1905–06

Reb Ezra lay awake in the upper farmhouse. The house was too full. Leybl had his bed in the kitchen and his cousins came up every evening to argue it out by the stove, one for Hirsh and one for Feivel, and the cows below the floor shifted and coughed all night, and nobody he spoke to listened to a word. He said to himself, *I could go up where there are no people.*

On Friday he came down for the Sabbath and stood in one shul and then walked to the other and stood there, and said nothing in either. On Sunday before light he put his tallis and tefillin in their bag, and a loaf and a block of cheese and a tin cup in a sack, and left the cows to Leybl, and went up the road without saying goodbye to anybody.

The first night he slept at the hut of an old man who burned charcoal alone in the woods above the Sheldrake Kill and had not spoken to another living soul since the fall. The old man was not a Jew and said he was nothing. They sat by his pit and watched the smoke come up out of the earth, and Reb Ezra told him, in his bad English, that he had picked a good way to live. The old man said, *I didn't pick it. Nobody would have me.* Reb Ezra said that was how most people picked things.

The second night he came down off the ridge to a cabin by a pond where three young men from the East Side were living out the winter, consumptives, sent up for the air. They were cutters from the same shop

on Division Street and had come up together, and they split their own wood and took turns cooking, and one of them read to the other two at night. When Reb Ezra asked them how they lived so well together in so small a place, the oldest one said, *Each of us does what the other two want, and we find out it's what I wanted.* Reb Ezra said to them, *Three bodies and one mind. I wish you could come down and teach on the hill.* He stayed a day with them and said the morning prayers with them, because they had forgotten how.

Then he went up into the hemlocks. Above the pond, in a hollow on the north side of the mountain, there was a shanty left from when the tanneries still ran, when the bark peelers had stripped the hemlocks all through those hills and left the trunks to lie. It had four walls and a roof and a stone fireplace. He swept it with a branch and lit a fire and stayed.

• • •

On Sheldrake Hill they missed him on the Sabbath. Gitl Rapoport went up to the farm herself and found Leybl milking.

Where is the Rov?

He went up into the woods.

For what?

He asked them to make peace and they wouldn't.

Gitl Rapoport came back down the hill and went from kitchen to kitchen. The two learned men had been eating their days the way scholars always had in the old country, Sunday at one table and Monday at another, a different farm every day of the week. That week there was no plate set for either of them anywhere. When Hirsh came to the Sabbath service, the women in the back did not wish him a good Sabbath. When Feivel came into the store the men at the stove looked at the stove. Nobody brought a chicken to the shochet. Nobody sent a boy to the melamed. Hirsh's wife fed him potatoes and Feivel lived on tea.

It took eight days. Then the two of them stood in the wagon shed and each asked the other's pardon in front of everybody, and each said he had been a fool, and they told Gitl Rapoport, *We've made peace. Let it be as before.*

Did you ask the Rov's pardon?

Not yet.

Then go ask him. When he forgives you, we'll set your plates.

That night it snowed, and it snowed for three days, and the drifts on the north road came up over the fences. Nobody could get up the mountain until spring. The two learned men spent the rest of that winter eating potatoes and tea.

IV. The Bear

The hemlock hollow · January to March 1906

What happened up there was told afterward by Amos Dibble, a Yankee who trapped mink along the Kill and had no reason to make up stories about Jews. He told it in the store at Centreville Station to anybody who would buy him a cigar, and he never changed it.

There was a big black bear in those woods, an old male, that had denned every winter under the same ledge. That year, Amos said, he didn't den. Amos had seen his sign around the ledge in the fall, two other bears and a sow with cubs crowding him out of his own place, the young ones tearing open his logs and the sow eating the beechnuts he wanted. It was as if he had looked at all of it and thought, *I could go off and be by myself.* And he came down through the snow to the hollow where the shanty was, where the old Jew was sitting on a log in the sun with his coat around him, and stood in front of him a long time, and then lay down.

After that he kept house. Amos saw it with his own eyes. The bear broke a hemlock bough off with his paw and swept the snow from the front of the shanty with it. He dragged in down wood for the fire. He carried water from the spring in the old man's bucket, holding the bail in his teeth, and set it by the hearth so it would warm. Amos said that in all that winter he never once saw the old man light the fire, and in all that winter he never once saw it out.

On Fridays Reb Ezra walked down to the Dibble place on the edge of the woods, because Mrs. Dibble was a Christian woman who would give

to anybody, and she gave him what a Jew was allowed to take from her, eggs and potatoes and once a sack of flour, and he baked his own Sabbath loaves in the ashes. The bear carried his sack in his mouth as far as the line of the woods. There the old man took it from him. *You can't come any farther than this,* he said. *Give it here.* And the bear sat down in the snow among the trees and waited, and when Reb Ezra came back up with his eggs the bear got up and took the sack again. At night, Amos said, the bear walked. Around and around the shanty in the dark, with a broken limb in his jaws, all night until the sun came up, so nothing would come near. Amos's dog would not go into that hollow. After that winter the hunters called it the Rabbi's Hollow, and some of them still call it that, without knowing why.

There was a raccoon too, Amos said. It came down out of a hollow beech on the warm days and watched the bear doing for the old man, and you could see it thinking. One afternoon it came out of the woods with a piece of honeycomb from a bee tree, frozen hard, nearly as big as its head, and laid it on the log next to Reb Ezra. Reb Ezra picked it up and looked at it and set it down again on his knee. The raccoon came and took it back and turned it over and over in its little black hands, the way they do, and found the brood cells in it, the young bees still in the comb, and picked out every one of them, one at a time, and gave it back to him clean. Reb Ezra said a blessing and ate it.

The raccoon went up the beech and ran out along the limbs and jumped from one to another as if it had lost its mind, and a dead limb broke under it, and it came down on the sharp stub of a broken hemlock and was killed.

The children on Sheldrake Hill, when they heard that part, said the raccoon went straight to heaven, and there was a little boy in the cheder who wouldn't let anybody say otherwise.

V. Leybl

The spring road · Adar

BY THE TIME THE ROADS OPENED, THE WHOLE COUNTY HAD heard that the old rabbi was living in the woods with a bear. A paper in Monticello printed a paragraph about it under the heading *A Hebrew Hermit*. Gitl Rapoport and Moishe Sacks, who kept the store and had given the land for the wagon shed, came to Leybl and said, *Bring him down. We want to see him.* A letter came from the Society in New York saying the same, more politely. And when the young men of the hill came home in March from their winter work in the city, they came to Leybl too. *We haven't heard him since the fall. Take us up.*

There were nineteen of them. Leybl took them up the north road and over the ridge and down past the pond, and when he could see the smoke from the shanty he stopped and told them to wait by the water. *He's been alone near three months. You don't walk in on a man like that with a crowd.* He went on alone.

The bear saw him first. It came out of the hollow at a run with the limb in its jaws, and Leybl stood where he was because there was nothing else to do.

Let him be, said Reb Ezra from the doorway. *Let him come. He's mine.*

The bear dropped the limb. It came and stood in front of Leybl and nosed at the sack on his shoulder, as if it wanted to carry it for him. Leybl did not give it up. He went to the shanty and saw his grandfather's bench in the sun by the door, the split log where the old man sat, and he did not set his sack on it. He set it on the ground. The bear watched him do it.

He kissed his grandfather's hand and sat down to one side.

You came alone?

The boys are down at the pond. Nineteen of them. I didn't know if you'd want them.

Tell them to come up.

They came up, and stood around in their city shoes in the snow, looking at the bear, which looked back at them. One of them said, *Rebbe,*

you've suffered up here. Alone in the woods all winter, an old man. Nobody to carry your water, nobody to cook.

Reb Ezra said the bear had carried his water. The bear had done everything. *If you find a good companion,* he said, *go with him, and be glad. If you can't find one, go alone. Better alone than with a fool.* Then he said it in the words of the Writings, the way he had taught most of them to say things when they were small.

> *He that walketh with wise men shall be wise; but the companion of fools shall smart for it.*
>
> *— Proverbs 13:20*

And because he could see from their faces what kind of winter it had been on the hill, he said the other one too, from the psalm.

> *And I said: 'Oh that I had wings like a dove! then would I fly away, and be at rest. Lo, then would I wander far off, I would lodge in the wilderness. Selah*
>
> *— Psalm 55:7–8*

The young men stood in the snow and something went through them that most of them never talked about afterward. Mottel Gross, the one who had told him to go home to his cows, sat down on the ground and put his face in his hands.

Then Leybl gave the message. *Gitl Rapoport says come down. Moishe Sacks says come down. The Society says. The whole hill wants you home.*

Good, said Reb Ezra. *Take my bag.*

VI. The Edge of the Woods

The north road · two days in March

THEY HAD NOT GONE FIFTY YARDS BEFORE THE BEAR WALKED out ahead of them and lay down across the path.

What does he want?

He wants to give you something before you go, said Reb Ezra. *He's done for me all winter. You don't hurt him. Turn around.*

So they turned around and went back to the shanty, twenty men in a shanty built for four, and slept on the floor and in the woodshed. In the morning there was food piled in front of the door: beechnuts, and frozen wild grapes, and cranberries from the bog, and apples. Apples in March, red, sound, as if they had just come off the tree. Nobody could say where the bear had found them. There was more than twenty men could eat, and they ate until they could not eat any more and filled their pockets, and Mottel Gross went home with apples in his hat.

Then Reb Ezra took his stick and started down, and the bear went past all of them and lay down across the path again, in front of him.

Now what?

Now he wants me to stay.

Reb Ezra stood and looked at the bear. *I'm going down,* he said to it, *and I won't come back. You can't come with me where I'm going. Up here there's nothing more for you to learn from me. Get up.*

The bear got up. It put a paw over its face and backed away into the hemlocks very slowly, and the young men said afterward that it made a sound none of them had ever heard come out of an animal. Then it came along behind them at a distance all the way down the north road, through the woods, to the stone wall where the Dibble fields began.

At the wall Reb Ezra turned around.

Here you stop, he said. *Past here it isn't safe for you. Down there they have guns and dogs. Stay.*

The bear stopped. It stood up against the wall on its hind legs to watch him go, with its paws on the top stones, and stayed like that while the old man went down across the white field with the young men around him, smaller and smaller, until he went into the trees on the other side and was gone.

Amos Dibble found it there the next morning, lying along the foot of the wall, dead, with no mark on it. He would not skin it. He and his boy dragged it back up into the woods with the team and put stones over it.

The children on Sheldrake Hill said it had gone where the raccoon went. Nobody had the heart to tell them different.

VII. The Water

The wagon shed · the Sabbath before Purim, 1906

When the two learned men heard that Reb Ezra was home, they put on their good coats to go up and beg his pardon.

The Society's man happened to be up from New York that week, Mr. Adler, to see about the loans, and when he heard who was coming he went to Reb Ezra. *Rabbi, I'll tell you frankly. I've had those letters. If it were up to me, neither of those two would set foot in that shul again.* Moishe Sacks said the same. It was his land the shul was on.

They're good men, said Reb Ezra. *They had a quarrel, and they didn't listen to me. Now they're coming to say so. Let them come.*

And Moishe Sacks was quiet.

On the Sabbath Reb Ezra had a bench set for the two of them by themselves, against the back wall, and nobody sat with them or stood near them. Every farmer and every farmer's wife and every child who came in through the door looked around and asked the same thing. *Where are they?* And Reb Ezra pointed. *There.* And they said it to each other all down the benches, *There they are, there,* and pointed with their chins, and the boys pointed with their fingers, until Hirsh Kagan and Feivel Melnik could not lift their heads. Then the two of them got up off their bench and came and went down on their knees on the floor in front of the old man and asked him to forgive them.

He said it was a hard thing they had done. He had raised them. He had brought them up this hill. They had heard him ask them three times, and they had not listened.

Then he told them the end of the story of the two inns, which he had never told on the hill before.

When Reb Dovid stood under the gallows in the marketplace, he said, and saw his son in the crowd, and said to him, *Not long, not short,* the people around Yankel thought the old man had lost his wits. But Yankel

understood him. Not long meant, do not carry your hatred a long time. Not short meant, do not be quick to break with a friend. Because hate is never finished by more hate. It is finished only by not hating. That is an old rule. Yankel kept his father's word while they were hanging his father, and he kept it in the sleigh with the knife in his hand. And afterward Zalman gave him his daughter, and when Zalman died Yankel kept both inns on the river, the upper and the lower, and people came from three districts to drink there because there was never a fight in either one.

He listened to his father while his father was dying, said Reb Ezra. *You couldn't listen to me while I was alive and standing in front of you.*

Then he got up, slowly, with his stick, and went out the back of the wagon shed to the privy, and the whole congregation came out behind him into the cold and stood in the yard. He took the washing cup and dipped it full from the barrel and washed his hands, right, left, right, left, right, left, the way they had all been taught as children. The water ran off his fingers into the tin basin. He held up the basin so they could all see it.

Then he walked past them out to the edge of the yard, where the snow lay unbroken in the shade of the woodpile and nobody ever walked, and poured it out.

> *For we must needs die, and are as water spilt on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again; neither doth God respect any person; but let him devise means, that he that is banished be not an outcast from him.*
>
> *— 2 Samuel 14:14*

Hirsh Kagan looked at the place where it had gone, and Feivel Melnik looked at it, and every person in that yard looked at it, the old women and the boys and the young men from the city and Mr. Adler of the Society in his Sabbath hat. Each of them would go into the ground on that hill or some other hill. The old man would go first, and then the rest of them, a few at a time, and not one of them would come back up to say who had been right about the basin.

Hirsh took the empty basin out of the old man's hands. Feivel took the cup. They hung them up together on the nail inside the privy door, where they had always hung, and went back in to finish the prayers.

Out by the woodpile the water had gone down into the snow and left a dark place the shape of a hand, already beginning to freeze at the edges.

Background

The verses

> *The world does not know that we must all come to an end here;—but those who know it, their quarrels cease at once.*
>
> Dhammapada 6, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If a man find a prudent companion who walks with him, is wise, and lives soberly, he may walk with him, overcoming all dangers, happy, but considerate.*
>
> Dhammapada 328, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If a man find no prudent companion who walks with him, is wise, and lives soberly, let him walk alone, like a king who has left his conquered country behind,—like an elephant in the forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 329, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *It is better to live alone, there is no companionship with a fool; let a man walk alone, let him commit no sin, with few wishes, like an elephant in the forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 330, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two monks of Kosambī, a teacher of the Dhamma and an expert in the monastic rules, fall out because one of them left his washing water standing in a vessel in the latrine. The quarrel splits their pupils, the lay supporters and, the text says, the gods up to the highest heaven. The Buddha asks them three times to make peace, tells them fables of quarrelling quails and the story of Prince Dīghāvu, who spared his father's killer, and is told to leave them to it. He walks off alone into the Protected Forest, where a great elephant who has left his own crowded herd serves him through the rains and a monkey brings him honey, picking out the insect eggs first. The lay people refuse the quarrelling monks seats and food until they repent. Ānanda comes with five hundred monks to bring the Buddha home; the elephant follows him to the edge of the village and dies of grief. The Buddha forgives the monks and closes with verse 6. Read the full commentary story.

Sullivan County, New York

Sullivan County, 1905-06

After the death of the financier Baron Maurice de Hirsch, his fund in New York incorporated the Jewish Agricultural and Industrial Aid Society in 1900 to help Jewish immigrants buy and keep farmland, including by issuing mortgage loans. Financed in large part by the Hirsch money, an organized effort moved Jews from the city tenements to thousands of small farms in the Neversink and Rondout valleys, especially in Sullivan County, and hundreds of them survived by taking in summer boarders. Some of the great resorts of the later Borscht Belt grew out of farms that Jewish immigrants established in the early twentieth century, in part because some established hotels advertised "No Hebrews or Consumptives." The New York, Ontario and Western Railway carried both the boarders and the milk.

Consumptives came anyway. Around 1900 the large Loomis Sanatorium for tuberculosis patients was established at Liberty, and the mountain air drew many more to farms and cottages. The woods they came to were second growth. Through much of the nineteenth century the Catskills' hemlock stands were cut for the tannin in their bark, until the tanneries closed one after another; at Grahamsville in Sullivan County the last one shut in 1878. The rule Feivel forgets belongs to Jewish ritual handwashing: by custom, water once used to wash the hands is not to be left standing where people pass or put to any other use, but poured away at once.

After the story of the monks of Kosambī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 6, with verses 328–330). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society Tanakh (1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.6

The Cooling Board

> *And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.*
> *— Matthew 7:25*

This is the way I heard it told, on Shawnee Run.

I. The Drove

The Harrodsburg road, Mercer County, Kentucky · November 1831

There were three Cole brothers on the Salt River below Harrodsburg, and the county told them apart by size. Josiah, the eldest, was Big Cole. Thomas, the youngest, was Little Cole, though he stood half a head taller than Josiah and always had. Absalom, in the middle, kept the store at the crossroads, and nobody called him anything but Ab.

Every fall, when the hogs had fattened on the mast, Big Cole and Little Cole bought up a drove in the Bluegrass and walked it south, down the Wilderness Road and through the Gap and over the mountains into Carolina, eight miles a day, buying corn at the stands as they went. They came home in February with money sewn into the linings of their coats and a wagon of coffee, sugar, calico and salt for Ab to sell, and the women of the three houses came out to the road to meet them.

That November they had four hundred and twenty hogs, six hired drivers and a wagon of corn, and on the Saturday night they turned the drove into a woods lot by the turnpike, a mile below the Shaker village at Pleasant Hill. The hogs settled. The drivers built a fire. Little Cole took off his boots.

On Sunday morning the road was full. Buggies came down from Lexington, and a carriage with a coachman, and farm wagons with whole families in the bed, and people on foot in their good clothes, all going the same way.

Where's everybody headed? Big Cole asked a man on a mule.

Shaker meeting. You never seen them dance?

Big Cole had heard about it his whole life and never gone. He was fifty-four years old. He stood a minute with his hat in his hand.

Tom, keep an eye on the hogs, he said. *I believe I'll go hear them.*

The meetinghouse was white and plain, with two doors in front. The world's people sat on benches along the walls. The Believers came in, the men by one door and the women by the other, and the men hung their coats on the pegs along the wall in a row, all alike, and stood in their shirtsleeves in ranks facing the women across the open floor. Nobody played an instrument. They sang, a tune with no words in it that Big Cole could catch, and then they began to step, forward and back, turning, all of them together, and their feet on the boards were like a hard rain on a tin roof. The floor gave under it. Big Cole felt it in the bench.

When the dance ended, a man stepped out from the rank of brothers to speak to the visitors. He was in his forties, lean, with big scarred hands that hung at his sides, and he looked at the benches a while before he said anything. Later Big Cole learned he was Elder Jonas, and that he was a joiner, and that he had made half the tables and chests in the village.

Elder Jonas did not shout. He talked about the things a man works for. A farm, a wife, children, hogs, a good name at the courthouse. He went down them one at a time as if he were counting boards. He said what each one costs, and what each one comes to, and who gets it after. He did not say any of it was wicked. He said a man goes out of the world the way he came in, and that his hogs do not go with him and his kin do not go with him, and then he went back to his place in the rank and they sang again.

Big Cole walked back down the turnpike in the cold with his hands in his coat. He had a farm on the Salt River and a brick house with an upstairs, and a wife and a mother and three daughters and two sisters-in-

law and a daughter-in-law under his roof, and four hundred and twenty hogs in a woods lot, and he understood, walking, that none of it was coming with him. He turned around at the creek and walked back up the hill.

Elder Jonas was in the yard by the meetinghouse with his coat on again. He listened. Then he asked a question.

Is there anybody you have to ask?

My brother, Big Cole said.

Go ask him.

• • •

Little Cole was sitting by the fire in his sock feet.

Tom, take it all, said Big Cole. *The hogs, the money, the wagon. Split it with Ab. I'm going up the hill.*

Little Cole argued until dark. He brought up Rhoda, Josiah's wife of thirty years. He brought up their mother, who was seventy-six and had buried a husband and two babies and would not live through this. He brought up the girls. He said the Shakers would take the farm, and when Josiah said the farm was Rhoda's from tonight and the hogs were Tom's, Little Cole said that was the craziest thing he had ever heard a grown man say and he had been to Frankfort when the legislature was sitting. Big Cole listened to all of it and nodded and did not change his mind, and at last Little Cole threw a stick in the fire.

All right, Josiah. Suit yourself.

On Monday morning he sent the drove on south with the head driver and a letter to Ab, and walked up the hill with his brother and gave his name at the Gathering Family too. He told himself it would take a month. A month of bean soup and singing, and Josiah would come to his senses, and Little Cole would be there to walk him home.

II. Two Labors

Pleasant Hill · winter 1831

The village sat on the high ground above the Kentucky River, where the river had cut down through the limestone and left cliffs

ON EITHER SIDE, GREY WALLS THREE HUNDRED FEET HIGH WITH red cedars growing out of the cracks. The Believers were building a great house of that stone, quarried out of the cliffs and hauled up the hill. They had been at it seven years and it was not done. Big Cole hauled stone. Little Cole was put in the broom shop, where he talked.

After a month Big Cole went to Elder Jonas in the joiner's shop. The Elder was planing a drawer front and did not stop.

How many works are there here? Big Cole asked him.

Two, said Elder Jonas. *One is to learn the gift. The songs, the steps, the order, the testimonies of Mother. Some of them are a long time learning it. The other is to labor with yourself until you're clean.*

I'm too old to learn all those songs, said Big Cole. *I can't keep the steps now. I'll take the other.*

Elder Jonas set the plane down and looked at him a while, the way he had looked at the benches.

Then go sit with the dead, he said. *After the retiring bell. Come in before the rising bell. I'll square it with your elders.*

So every night, when the family had knelt and gone up the brothers' stair to bed, Big Cole went out by the brothers' door and across the frozen pasture to the burying ground on the rise, and sat down among the graves. The Believers buried their dead in rows, the brothers and the sisters, with the same plain marker over each. There were a good many of them by then. He sat on the ground with his back to the fence and his coat buttoned up. Sometimes he stood and walked the rows. Sometimes he sat until his legs went dead. At four in the morning, before the bell, he crossed the pasture again and went in.

In the broom shop, Little Cole tied broomcorn and talked about his wife Polly, and her biscuits, and her sister Jane who lived with them and could not be got to marry, and the store, and how Ab would be making a hash of the accounts without him, and the hogs, wherever they were by now. He talked about his brother.

Sitting out in a graveyard all night in January, he said. *I couldn't do it. I wouldn't. That's a hard thing he's doing.*

III. The Rules

The burying ground · winter and spring 1832

Sister Dorcas had laid out every sister who died at Pleasant Hill for sixteen years, and dug some of their graves. She had come over the mountains from Virginia as a girl, the property of a family who heard the Shakers preach and signed the covenant, and when that family lost its faith and went back to the world, the Society paid them her price so she could stay. She sat at the end of the sisters' rank in meeting. She ate where she was put. She kept the key to the little stone house by the burying ground where the bodies waited, and she kept the burying ground, and she had seen a man in it at night.

She watched him for most of a week. He came after the retiring bell and went before the rising bell. He did not dig. He did not carry anything. He sat, and stood, and walked the rows. She could not make him out.

So one night she lit the lantern in the dead-house and left it burning in the window, and took the two children from the Children's Order who were given to her charge, a boy and a girl, and waited with them behind the cedar at the corner of the fence. When the man came over the pasture and sat down, she came out with the children holding her skirt.

Brother, she said. *Do you stay here?*

Yes, Sister.

Then there's rules for staying here.

He was a white man and a rich one, or had been, and she had known plenty of men like him to tell her that her rules were none of his concern. He took off his hat.

What ought I to do, Sister?

You tell the Elder you're out here. You tell the Trustee. And you tell the squire down at Harrodsburg.

The squire?

The doctors' boys come out from Lexington with a wagon and spades, she said. *They want the new ones, for cutting. Somebody hears them and runs them off, and they drop what they've got and go, and whoever comes after them finds*

a body on the ground and a man sitting in the burying ground at three in the morning. You want people to say, that's Brother Josiah, he's sat out here every night since November, he's no resurrection man.

Big Cole thought about that. *Is there anything else?*

As long as you sit out here, you don't eat meat. Not pork, not beef, not fish. No grease. No wheat bread. No molasses, no honey. Cornbread and beans and water. You don't sleep in the daytime. You don't idle. You don't say one thing to the Elder and another to me. You come after the bell and you go before the bell. She shifted the boy on her hip. *And I'll tell you this. If you come to what you're looking for out here, then when they bring me the next one I'll lay it out with lavender and rosemary and sing over it. And if you don't, I'll roll it in the hole like a sack of meal and stamp the dirt down on it.*

All right, said Big Cole. *Sister, if they bring you one that would teach me something, would you come and tell me?*

She looked at him a long time over the lantern.

I'll do that, she said.

He went down to Harrodsburg the next week and told the squire, who thought he was making a joke.

IV. The Cooling Board

July 1832

The summer came in hot and stayed. The corn curled in the fields by noon. The Trustee came back from Lexington with a newspaper and said there was cholera in New York, a hundred dying in a day, and that it was coming down the rivers.

Lovina Shryock was seventeen. Her mother had brought her to the Children's Order when she was six, and her father, who grew hemp in Woodford County and did not believe in anything, had never forgiven any of them. She had a high clear voice that came over the top of the singing. She had a face that the brothers were taught not to look at and looked at anyway, across the open floor, in the dance, so that more than once a brother lost the step, and once a whole rank of them came down a half-beat late with a sound like a dropped load of lumber, and the Elder

stopped the meeting. Big Cole had looked at her too. He had been a man in the world for fifty-four years.

On a Thursday evening she sat down on the bench by the wash house and said she was tired, and an hour later she was dead. There was no fever and no sweating. She had not been sick a day. The doctor said it was her heart, and could not say why.

Her father sent a rider. He was coming, and nobody was to put her in the ground before he saw her. So Sister Dorcas washed her and dressed her in a clean white gown and laid her on the cooling board in the dead-house by the burying ground, with a sheet over her and coins on her eyes and cloths soaked in soda water laid on her face and hands to keep the color, and when she had done all that, she went out in the dusk to the man who sat by the fence.

Brother Josiah, she said. *I have one to show you.*

He came. She lifted the sheet, and took the cloths away. He looked at Lovina Shryock from the soles of her feet to her hair, a long time, the way he had once looked over a hog before he bought it. She was as she had been in meeting. She was more so. There was not a mark on her.

Cover her, he said. *When the heat has hold of her, come and tell me.*

And he went back to his place by the fence and sat down.

Friday was the hottest day of that summer. The dead-house was stone and half sunk in the hill, but it was not enough. Sister Dorcas wet the cloths every hour and it was not enough. The father did not come on Friday. At dusk she went out to the fence.

Big Cole came and stood by the cooling board, and she lifted the sheet.

Where the heat had taken hold, the girl's skin had gone mottled, like the hide of a roan cow, dark and pale in patches. Her feet had swelled and turned outward and hung over the end of the board. Her hands had drawn back at the wrists. When Sister Dorcas lifted the cloth from her forehead, the skin came with it.

Big Cole did not turn away. He looked at her the way he had looked the night before, from her feet to her hair. He thought: this is the face that made a whole rank of grown men lose the step. A day ago. Yesterday.

Then he went out and sat down by the fence among the graves, and stayed there through the short hot night, saying one verse over to himself, over and over, the way a man says a thing to get the shape of it.

> *For the sun is no sooner risen with a burning heat, but it withereth the grass, and the flower thereof falleth, and the grace of the fashion of it perisheth: so also shall the rich man fade away in his ways.*
>
> *— James 1:11*

Sister Dorcas saw him from the door of the dead-house a little before four. He was sitting with his hands open on his knees. She did not know what had happened to him, and she did not ask, but she knew that something had, and she had kept her side of the bargain all her life.

Lovina's father came on Saturday and stood in the door of the dead-house with his handkerchief over his mouth, and would not go in, and went back to Woodford County. They buried her that evening. Sister Dorcas laid lavender and rosemary in the box, and sang over her in a voice nobody at Pleasant Hill had heard her use, low and strong, and the sisters who had come out with her looked at each other.

V. A Coat and a Hat

The Salt River · September 1832

Late that summer Elder Jonas went out on a journey with six brothers to open the testimony in the country south of Harrodsburg, and the Cole brothers went with him, because the country was theirs.

The word went ahead of them. In Little Cole's house on the Salt River, Polly and her sister Jane heard it and looked at each other across the churn.

Now we'll get him back, said Polly.

So they sent word to the Elder that he and his brethren were welcome to hold meeting at the Coles' and take their dinner there. Elder Jonas would not eat in a house of the world unless it was set in the Believers'

order, so one brother always went on ahead to tell the family how things were to be set, since the Believers did not sit as the world sat: the brothers at one table and the sisters at another, the elders at the head, and the meal taken in silence. Big Cole, who was standing with the brothers' hats, turned to his younger brother.

Tom, you go on ahead and tell them how to set the tables.

Polly and Jane saw him coming down the lane in his broad hat and his drab coat with no collar on it, and they started laughing before he reached the gate. While he stood in the yard explaining, they carried the tables out and set them up wrong on purpose. They put the nail kegs at the head, where the Elder was to sit, and the good chairs at the foot. They set the men's places and the women's places side by side.

That's not right, said Little Cole. *You've got the low seats up top and the high seats down the bottom. The Elder doesn't sit on a keg.*

They acted as if they had not heard him.

Who are you to be giving orders in this yard? said Polly. *Who told you you could go off to the Shakers? Who took you in? What are you doing here?*

And laughing, the two of them, they took hold of him and pulled the drab coat off his back and the broad hat off his head. Jane went in the house and came out with his blue broadcloth wedding coat and the flowered waistcoat he had worn to the Fourth of July barbecue at Harrodsburg, and they got him into them, and Polly picked a fistful of goldenrod out of the fence row and stuck it in the band of his old straw hat and set it on his head.

Now go and fetch your Elder, she said. *We'll set the tables.*

Little Cole had been a Shaker for ten months. He had never learned the songs, and he had never really learned to be ashamed of anything either, and he did not mind the coat. It fit him. He walked back up the lane in the blue broadcloth with the goldenrod in his hat and met the Elder and the brethren at the creek, and said dinner was ready, and led them down to the house.

They ate. Nobody said a word about the coat. When the Elder and the brothers walked back up the lane that afternoon, Little Cole was standing at the gate with his wife.

VI. The Roof

Big Cole's house · the next day

In the brick house a mile down the river, Rhoda Cole heard about it before dark.

Big Cole's house held eight women. There was Rhoda, who had been married to him thirty years. There was his mother, seventy-six. There were their three daughters, Sarah, Lucy and little Rhoda. There were Rhoda's widowed sisters Ellen and Prudence, who had come to live with them after the fever of 1822, and their son William's wife Martha, who stayed with them while William was off in Missouri. Ab's house up the road held four, and Little Cole's held two. People in the county did the arithmetic.

Polly got hers back, said Rhoda. *We'll get ours.*

So the next day the Elder and the brethren were invited to the brick house. But that morning a different brother went ahead to tell them how to set the tables, a quiet young man from the West Family named Brother Eli, and Rhoda's women could not think how to make sport of him, and set everything as he asked. The brothers ate at one table and the sisters at another, and the Elder sat at the head, and the meal was taken in silence. Big Cole ate cornbread and beans and drank water.

When they had finished, Rhoda came and stood by the Elder's chair.

Elder, she said, *Josiah always gave thanks at this table. Let him stay and kneel with his family and return thanks the old way, and he'll come along after you.*

Very well, said Elder Jonas, and got up, and put on his hat, and went out the gate.

The brethren followed him up the river road, and before they had gone a quarter of a mile they were muttering among themselves.

Did he do that knowing, or not knowing? they said. *Yesterday Thomas went ahead and that was the end of Thomas. Today it's Josiah. He's a good brother. He's as steady as they come. Will they take him too?*

Elder Jonas stopped in the road.

What are you saying back there?

They told him.

You think Josiah is like Thomas?

Elder, said one of them, *Thomas had two women in his house, and they got him. Josiah has eight. If eight women get hold of a man, what can he do?*

Elder Jonas looked back down the road at the brick house. The sun was on the roof.

Thomas was busy every minute, he said. *He let his mind go wherever it was pleased to go, and it was pleased to go everywhere. Josiah sat with the dead.* And then he said the rest of it, standing in the dust of the river road with the brethren around him, in the voice he used for counting boards.

> *Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock: And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.*
>
> *And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand: And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it.*
>
> *— Matthew 7:24–27*

In the brick house the eight women had closed the door.

They stood around Big Cole in a ring, his mother and his wife and his daughters and his wife's sisters, and they talked at him all at once. Who gave you leave? Who told you you could go? Thirty years, Josiah. Your mother, Josiah. Look at your mother. Will you come home now? Will you come home? And they took hold of his drab coat, the sleeves and the collarless neck of it, all of them together, to pull it off his back.

This next part is the part people on the Salt River tell, and they tell it the same way every time.

Big Cole stood up from the table. He did not push anybody. He went straight up, the way a man gets up out of a chair, and kept going, and the women's hands came off his coat one at a time as he rose out of their reach. He went up through the ceiling and through the loft, and the roof

of the brick house opened over him, and the oak shingles went up into the air all at once, a whole square yard of them, like a covey of quail flushed out of a fence row. Rhoda's sister Prudence said afterward that she saw the soles of his boots. The girls said there was sky where the roof had been. The neighbor across the river, who was pulling fodder, looked up and saw the shingles in the air and a man among them, and said so to the end of his life, to anybody, sober or not.

Up the river road, Elder Jonas came to the end of the verse. *And great was the fall of it,* he said. And Big Cole came down out of the air and stood in the road in front of him, in his drab coat, with his broad hat in his hand, and a little plaster dust on his shoulders.

The brethren did not mutter any more after that. They walked back to Pleasant Hill without a word among them, the eight of them, in a line, and Big Cole at the end of the line where he liked to be.

• • •

Little Cole lived another forty years on the Salt River and ran the store with Ab and drove hogs south every November until the railroad came. He was a good brother to everybody and a good husband to Polly, and he never did learn to sit still. He told the story of the roof himself, at the store, the same as everybody else did, and when he got to the shingles he always laughed.

Rhoda had the roof mended that same week, with new white oak shingles split out of a tree on the place. For a long time you could see it from the road, a bright square in the grey, where the hole had been. Then the rain came, and the frost, and the summer sun, and did to the new shingles what it does, until they were as grey as all the rest, and you could not have told anybody where it was.

Background

The verses

> *He who lives looking for pleasures only, his senses uncontrolled, immoderate in his food, idle, and weak, Mara (the tempter) will certainly overthrow him, as the wind throws down a weak tree.*
>
> Dhammapada 7, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who lives without looking for pleasures, his senses well controlled, moderate in his food, faithful and strong, him Mara will certainly not overthrow, any more than the wind throws down a rocky mountain.*
>
> Dhammapada 8, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two merchant brothers, Mahā Kāḷa and Culla Kāḷa, are halted with their caravan of five hundred carts when the elder hears the Buddha teach and decides to go forth. The younger follows him into the order, privately meaning to bring him home. Mahā Kāḷa practices at night in a charnel ground, where Kāḷī, the woman who burns the dead, gives him her rules and promises to show him a fitting body. She shows him a beautiful young woman who died suddenly, and he asks to be told when the fire has taken hold. He sees the burned body and reaches awakening. When the Buddha visits the brothers' town, Culla Kāḷa's wives mock him, strip off his robes and send him back into lay life. Mahā Kāḷa's eight wives try the same thing the next day. While the monks are asking whether he can hold out, the Buddha speaks of the weak tree and the rocky mountain, and Mahā Kāḷa rises through the roof of the house and comes down at the Teacher's feet. Read the full commentary story.

Pleasant Hill, Kentucky

Pleasant Hill, Kentucky, 1832

The Shakers (the United Society of Believers in Christ's Second Appearing) followed Mother Ann Lee, lived celibate and held their property in common. Brothers and sisters lived as separate orders under one roof, and their worship was a disciplined dance. Missionaries from New Lebanon, New York, came to Kentucky after the great revivals of 1801, and in 1806 converts near Harrodsburg signed a covenant that became Pleasant Hill, on the high ground above the Kentucky River palisades. By the early 1830s it had several communal families, including a gathering family for newcomers, along with a meetinghouse built in 1820 to take the shock of the dancing and a great Centre Family dwelling of limestone, begun in 1824 and finished in 1834. The Sunday meetings drew curious visitors from the surrounding country. When a married person joined, the spouse left behind sometimes fought back, in court and in print, and those quarrels were among the bitterest in the Shakers' history. The village is preserved today as Shaker Village of Pleasant Hill.

The Pleasant Hill Shakers opposed slavery in a slave state and bought the freedom of enslaved people who wished to stay among them. Over the community's history about twenty-eight Black and mixed-race Believers lived there, often, as the village's own historians note, at the margins of its social life. Kentucky drovers walked hogs, cattle and mules south across the mountains to the Carolina markets, about eight miles a day. American medical schools were short of cadavers, and grave robbing for the dissecting rooms was a real fear. Families watched new graves at night. In the summer of 1832 Asiatic cholera reached New York and spread down the river valleys, and in 1833 it killed about one Lexingtonian in fourteen.

After the story of Culla Kāḷa and Mahā Kāḷa from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 7 and 8). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.7

Four Votes

> *but the raiment of restraint from evil, that is best.*
> *— Qur'an 7:26*

Ovako sam čuo, on Gravois Avenue.

I. The Guests

Bevo Mill, St. Louis, Missouri · Ramadan, June 2017

For the last ten nights of Ramadan the džemat on Gravois had two guests from Bosnia. Hafiz Senad Mehić taught at a medresa in Sarajevo and carried the whole Qur'an in his head, and he had been sent for the month, the way scholars are sent every year to the congregations abroad, to lead the long night prayers and recite. With him came a young muezzin named Adem. They slept in the two rooms over the hall, which had been a furniture store, and they had one suitcase each.

Nobody let them eat a meal alone. To feed a guest who is fasting is counted a great good, a sevap, and the families of Bevo had divided up the thirty evenings back in April, by twos and threes and sometimes a whole street together. Emir Selimović's wife had the eleventh night with her sisters and cooked for two days.

Emir drove a truck. A good third of the men in the džemat did. He was thirty-six and owned his own Freightliner, leased on to Fadil Kovač's company, and ran refrigerated freight to upstate New York and back. He had come to America at sixteen, to Utica, with his mother and without his father, and to St. Louis at twenty-two because a cousin said there was work and the houses were cheap.

On the twenty-fifth night, after the dates and the soup, the hafiz stood up at the end of the long tables to thank the families who had cooked. He

was a narrow man with a short gray beard and he spoke quietly, so that the back tables had to stop scraping their chairs.

One man gives, and never asks his neighbor to give, he said. *On the other side that man will find his table full and nobody sitting at it. Another man goes up and down the street telling everybody else to give, and gives nothing himself. He will find a crowd around him and no bread. A third neither gives nor asks. He will not get so much as a bowl of thin sour soup. And the fourth gives, and goes and knocks on his neighbor's door as well. That one will have the bread and the company both, a hundred times over, a thousand times, more times than I can count for you.*

Then he recited, and gave it afterward in plain words for the young people, who had their Arabic from Saturday school and their Bosnian from their grandmothers.

> *Hast thou observed him who belieth religion?*
> *That is he who repelleth the orphan,*
> *And urgeth not the feeding of the needy.*
>
> *— Qur'an 107:1–3*

You see what is counted against him, the hafiz said. *That he did not urge.* And he sat down and asked for more of the soup.

II. The Thousand

Gravois Avenue · the next two days

Mirsad Begić had the bakery across from the windmill. He had given all his life. He had never once asked. He lay awake on it, and in the morning he went up the stairs over the hall.

Efendija, tomorrow is the twenty-seventh night. Be my guest.

Gladly. How many are you feeding?

How many come to pray on the twenty-seventh night?

With the people from Affton and the county, they tell me a thousand.

Then bring the thousand.

He went down Gravois with a notebook. He went into the butcher's and the cafés and the insurance office and the place that sent money home, and he stood in the door of each and said the same thing. *I have invited a thousand people to break the fast tomorrow. How many can you feed? How many can you?*

They told him. The butcher said two hundred and wrote down six lambs. The women of Itaska Street said a hundred, in pita, cheese and potato and meat. A widow on Morganford said ten, and it was the most she could do, and he wrote it down the same size as the lambs. The trucking men said the tea and the sugar and the dates and the water, for everyone. By evening the notebook came to a thousand and some over.

Good, Mirsad said. *Now nobody cooks at home. Bring it all to the hall and we cook it as one house.* So the flour came, and the onions and the lamb, the walnuts and the sugar and the tubs of kajmak, and all that night and the next day the hall smelled like a wedding. Mirsad baked eleven hundred somuns and for the first time in twenty years did not sell one.

Emir peeled onions with the other drivers at a folding table by the back door, forty-pound sacks of them, and wept with the rest and was laughed at by the women. Nermin Hadžić was there too, as he was everywhere, in his black robe, showing the boys how to turn the spits.

Late in the afternoon Fadil Kovač came in with a dry cleaner's bag over his arm. Fadil had forty trucks. He laid the bag on the table where the women were cutting baklava, and unzipped it, and the women put down their knives.

It was a ćurak, the long fur-lined cloak that judges and scholars wore in the old days, the wool the yellow of a ripe quince and the lining red fox. Fadil's great-grandfather had been a kadija in Foča, and the cloak had been made for him in Sarajevo in the time of the Austrians. In April of 1992 Fadil's mother had walked out of Foča with it folded in a plastic shopping bag under two loaves of bread. It had lain since in a cedar chest with rose oil, and when he opened the bag the whole end of the hall smelled of roses.

A dealer in Chicago offered me thirty thousand dollars, Fadil said. *If the food comes up short, sell it to him and buy what you need. If there is enough,*

give it to whichever efendija you see fit. It should be on somebody's shoulders. It has been in a box for a hundred years.

III. The Count

The hall · the twenty-seventh night

THERE WAS ENOUGH. A THOUSAND AND SIXTY PEOPLE BROKE the fast at tables that ran out the back door and across the parking lot, and when the last of them had eaten there were somuns left to send to the shelter on Chippewa and lamb to send home with the students. Nothing had to be sold.

So after the night prayer, while the men were stacking chairs, Mirsad held up the cloak in its bag. *Brothers, this was given for a purpose, and the purpose is met. Who gets it?*

The hafiz, somebody said, and a good many said it after him. *Who else?*

Then Zijad the roofer spoke up from the back. *The hafiz is a fine man. The hafiz comes when the cherries are ripe and goes home before the plums. Who is here in February? Who washed my father's body? Who stood in line with my mother at Social Security for four hours? Nermin. Nermin is here on Bajram and he is here on a wet Tuesday. He's like the sebilj on the corner. Give it to Nermin.*

Nermin Hadžić had no diploma from any medresa. He had a good voice and a black robe, and when the imam was away he led the prayer. He washed the dead. He recited at the seventh day and the fortieth. He knew which window at the county building and which form. There was hardly a family in the hall he had not done something for, and it was true that he was always there.

They talked it over for an hour. In the end Mirsad said to raise hands, and counted, and did not trust it, and counted again. It was a hundred and thirty-one for Nermin and a hundred and twenty-seven for the hafiz. Four votes.

One of them was Emir's. Nermin had sat with him through his citizenship forms in 2009, question by question. Emir had paid him sixty dollars

for it and thought nothing of it. He put his hand up, and then he went home to sleep three hours before he had to drive.

The hafiz had been at the sink the whole time with his sleeves rolled, washing the big pots. When they told him the count he said, *May he wear it in health,* and asked for a dry towel.

Nermin took the cloak that night to Rasim the tailor on Delor Street. A long cloak is no use in America, he said. He had Rasim cut it off at the hip to make a jacket, and make a vest out of the skirt, with the fox showing at the collar of each. And since the yellow had faded along the folds, he had the whole of it dipped, the color of strong tea. Rasim did what he was paid to do. He kept the pieces he cut away in a drawer and did not say why.

By Friday Nermin was walking up Gravois in the jacket and the vest, one over the other. People stopped to shake his hand and look. When he had gone by, they said it to each other quietly, in front of the butcher's and the bakery. *It doesn't sit on him. On the hafiz it would have sat. Look how he goes about in it.*

IV. Exit 31

Utica, New York · Friday, June 23

Emir went out at three on Thursday morning with forty thousand pounds of frozen ravioli for a warehouse in Syracuse. A traveler is excused from the fast and can make up the days in winter, when they are short. He kept it anyway. The cab was cool, and it gave him something to do with Ohio. He wrote his hours in the paper log with a ruler, as he always had. In December the government was going to put a box in every truck to do it for him.

Indiana went by in the dark and Ohio in the heat. On the phone the Bosnian drivers kept one another awake the way they always did, one long conversation running from Des Moines to Jacksonville about the price of diesel and whose son was marrying whose daughter, and that day it was all the cloak. Before Columbus he had heard his own vote described to him by a man in Kentucky who did not know whose it was.

He was empty by ten on Friday, and at noon he came off the Thruway at Exit 31 and parked the tractor behind the mosque that had been a Methodist church. Then he walked four blocks with a bag of Mirsad's somuns to see his bula.

Hatidža Hadžiavdić was seventy-four. In the village above the Drina where she was born she had been the bula, the woman who teaches the children their letters and leads the women's prayers for the dead, and she had kept a class in the room over the shop all through the years when the state would have preferred she did not. In 1992 the men who came to the village killed her husband and her son on the same afternoon. She had been in Utica since 1997. She taught the children there on Saturdays, in the church basement, and in 1998 she had taught a boy of seventeen who was ashamed to be learning his alif-ba with eight-year-olds. She sat him at her own kitchen table instead, in the evenings, and nobody knew.

She looked at the somuns and put them in the freezer for the evening and made him sit.

Two of mine are in your city this month, she said. *Senad was the quickest child I ever had. He had the short suras before he had his front teeth. Does he still read too fast? And Nermin was in the same class, on the same bench. How are my two boys?*

So Emir told her. He told her about the thousand and the notebook, the widow's ten, the cloak that smelled of roses. He told her about the count and about his own hand. And he told her what he had seen on his phone at a truck stop outside Erie, in a photograph his wife sent, Nermin on Gravois in a jacket the color of tea with a fox collar.

The bula listened to all of it with her hands flat on the oilcloth.

That is not the first time Nermin has put on something that didn't suit him, she said. *When he was nine the old hodža left his turban on the windowsill to dry. Nermin put it on his head and went from house to house collecting eggs for the mosque. He got forty eggs. The mosque did not see one.* She looked out the window at the neighbor's tomatoes. *My grandmother had a story about a man like that. She told it at the loom, and you had to hold the wool or she stopped.*

V. The Spring

Her grandmother's story

In the time of the sultans, the bula said, there was a spring under a cliff, and beside the spring a house of dervishes. They were poor men. Each had a bowl and one cloak, a hrka, patched until you could not find the first cloth.

Red deer lived in the beech woods above, a great herd of them, and they came down a certain path every morning to the meadows and went back by it at night. One day the deer saw the dervishes at the spring. From that day, going and coming, every deer that passed stopped on the path and bent its forelegs and lowered its head to the ground, as a deer does to drink, though there was no water in that place. Then it got up and went on.

There was a hunter in the town who lived by killing deer and selling the hide and the antler and the meat. Deer are hard to come near. He watched them on the path, and he thought, what is it they see that makes them go down like that? He decided it was the cloak. So he waited by the spring until one of the dervishes took off his hrka to wash for prayer and laid it on a rock, and he stole it.

The next morning he sat down beside the path with the cloak drawn over his head and a spear under it. The deer came down. They saw the cloak and knelt, each one, and rose and went on. The last of them he killed, with one thrust, while its head was on the ground. He took what he could sell and buried the rest. He did the same the next day, and the next.

After some time a new stag came to lead that herd. He was bigger than the others, and he noticed things. He saw that the herd had grown small. *Where are they going?* he asked. Nobody knew. He thought about the man who sat by the path every morning with a cloak over his head, and he thought, that one wants watching.

The next morning he sent all the others ahead and came last himself, slowly. The deer knelt and passed. When the hunter saw the big stag coming he drew the cloak aside and threw the spear. But the stag had

kept his eyes on him the whole way down, and he stepped back, and the spear went by. *This is the one who has been killing mine,* the stag thought, and he went for him. The hunter ran behind a walnut tree and crouched there. The stag lowered his head to take the man and the tree together and break him against it.

Then the hunter pulled off the cloak and held it out in front of him, around the tree, where the stag could see it.

The stag stopped. He stood with his horns a hand's width from the cloth. He thought, if I strike a man who is holding that, I am shamed in front of every true one who ever wore it. And he held himself back, though it shook him to do it.

Was it you who killed my people?

It was, said the hunter.

Why would you do a thing like that? You have put on a cloak that suits a man who has finished with wanting. It does not suit you. You did a great wrong when you put it on, before you ever picked up the spear.

That was all he did to him. He told him so, and went down to the meadow.

• • •

Emir had been fourteen in July of 1995. He had gone out of Potočari on a bus with his mother. His father and his uncle had gone the other way, into the woods, with the column of men that tried to walk to Tuzla. His uncle was one of those who got there. He told it once, in Utica, at this table, and the bula had been in the room. He said that on the second day there were men down on the asphalt road in blue helmets, with a white vehicle, calling up into the trees through a loudspeaker that it was safe now, that the United Nations was here, to come down. Emir's father had gone down.

The bula did not mention it. She got up and put the kettle on for the evening, though it was hours yet, and stood with her back to him until it had no more reason to take so long.

VI. Raiment

Utica · that evening, and St. Louis · Sunday, June 25

He stayed to break the fast with her. The sun went down at a quarter to nine. They ate Mirsad's bread and her soup at the kitchen table where he had learned his letters, and afterward she spoke about it once more and not again.

Senad gave you the first half of that sura, she said. *He is polite. He stops before the hard part. I am old and I will give you the rest.*

> *Ah, woe unto worshippers*
> *Who are heedless of their prayer;*
> *Who would be seen (at worship)*
> *Yet refuse small kindnesses!*
>
> *— Qur'an 107:4–7*

Nermin does not refuse them. He sells them. Sixty dollars, you said. For a widow it is forty, I hear, he is not a monster. A kindness with a price on it is a shop. There is no sin in keeping a shop. But you don't give a shopkeeper the kadija's cloak.

She gathered the crumbs on the oilcloth into her palm.

And the cloak itself. Listen. He told us there were two kinds of clothes, and He told us which one He meant.

> *O Children of Adam! We have revealed unto you raiment to conceal*
> *your shame, and splendid vesture, but the raiment of restraint from evil,*
> *that is best. This is of the revelations of Allah, that they may remember.*
>
> *— Qur'an 7:26*

A man who has not washed himself out, who does not hold himself back, who is loose with the truth, can be voted any cloak you like. It will hang on him like washing on a fence. And the one who has cleaned out what was in him, and stands steady, and holds back, and is true, that one is wearing it already. You could give him a flour sack. Tell them that on Gravois. Say the old woman said it.

At the door she put a paper bag in his hand. It held a pair of wool socks, gray, with a red band, the kind the village women knit. *For Senad. For the winter. Tell him he still reads too fast.*

• • •

He loaded yogurt at New Berlin on Saturday at dawn and drove his eleven hours and slept his ten outside Dayton, and so he missed the Bajram prayer. He came down Gravois a little before noon on Sunday with the windows open. They were all still there, in the lot behind the hall, under the pop-up tents, the girls in their new dresses, the old men kissing one another on both cheeks, the last of the lamb on paper plates.

He said what she had told him to say. He said it to Mirsad first, at the tea urn, and then to Zijad the roofer, and each of them carried it to another table, and by one o'clock it had been around the lot and people were standing a little differently.

Nermin was by the fence having his picture taken with a family from Affton. He wore the jacket over the vest. It was June in St. Louis and the sun was straight overhead, and he was lined with fox. He smiled for the telephone and then for another telephone. The tea-colored dye had started to come off the collar. There was a brown line around his neck where it touched, and below it the color was going down into his white shirt, slowly, like water into a sugar cube.

The hafiz was stacking chairs. He had taken off his black robe after the prayer and folded it over the fence, and he was in his shirtsleeves, carrying four chairs at a time. Emir gave him the paper bag. The hafiz looked inside, and then he held the socks against his face with both hands and breathed in, and stood like that long enough that Emir looked away.

She says you read too fast.

She has said it for forty years. He pushed the socks down into his shirt pocket, where they made a gray lump over his heart with the red band showing, and went back for more chairs.

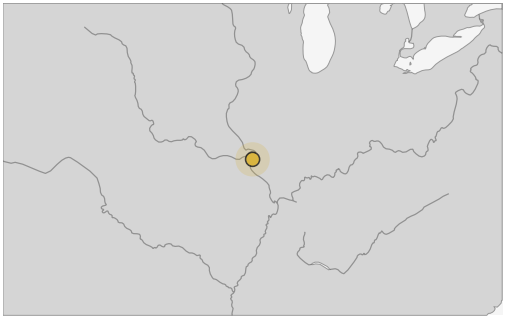
Background

The verses

> *He who wishes to put on the yellow dress without having cleansed himself from sin, who disregards temperance and truth, is unworthy of the yellow dress.*
>
> Dhammapada 9, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But he who has cleansed himself from sin, is well grounded in all virtues, and regards also temperance and truth, he is indeed worthy of the yellow dress.*
>
> Dhammapada 10, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha's two chief disciples visit Rājagaha, and Sāriputta preaches on the four kinds of givers: those who give, those who urge others to give, those who do neither and those who do both. A layman is moved to feed all thousand monks and canvasses the city; the food is pooled and cooked in one place. A householder adds a perfumed yellow robe worth a hundred thousand, to be sold if the food falls short and otherwise given to any monk. By a majority of four the people give it to Devadatta, who is always among them, "ever ready like a waterpot," and not to Sāriputta, who comes and goes. Devadatta cuts it up and wears it, and people say it does not suit him. When the Buddha hears of it he tells of an elephant hunter who stole a holy man's robe so that the elephants would kneel to him, and of the elephant king who caught him and spared him out of respect for the robe. In Pāli the verses turn on a pun between *kasāva*, a stain, and *kāsāva*, the dyed robe. Read the full commentary story, or about Devadatta.



Bevo Mill, St. Louis, Missouri

Little Bosnia, 2017

During and after the Bosnian war of 1992–1995, St. Louis took in more Bosnian refugees than any other American city. With later arrivals from other states the community grew to an estimated 70,000, centered on the old German neighborhood of

Bevo Mill, where Bosnians opened bakeries, butcher shops, cafés and trucking firms (see Bosnian Americans). In 2014 the community gave the city a replica of the Sebilj, the wooden public fountain in Sarajevo's old market. Utica, New York, has another large Bosnian community. The džemat, its people and its hall in this story are invented. A *hafiz* is someone who has memorized the Qur'an; a *bula* is a Bosnian woman who teaches children and leads women's religious gatherings; a *ćurak* is a fur-lined cloak. In 2017 Ramadan ended with Bajram (Eid al-Fitr) on June 25, and American truckers still kept paper logs; electronic logging devices became mandatory that December.

In July 1995, after Bosnian Serb forces took the United Nations "safe area" of Srebrenica, women and children were deported by bus from the UN base at Potočari, and a column of some ten to fifteen thousand men tried to walk through the woods to Tuzla. More than eight thousand men and boys were killed in what international courts have ruled a genocide. The trial judgment in the Krstić case records that soldiers called to the men in the forest with megaphones, and that some used stolen UN equipment to make them believe the UN was present to see them treated properly. The Qur'an passages are from Marmaduke Pickthall's translation, *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran* (1930); sura 107 is the one he titles "Small Kindnesses."

After the story of Devadatta from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 9 and 10). The original. Scripture from the Qur'an in Marmaduke Pickthall's translation (1930). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

1.8

Heart and Sap

A merry Life and a short one, shall be my Motto.
— Captain Charles Johnson, A General History of the Pyrates (1724)

This is how the old people told it, on Harbour Island.

I. Braziletto

Harbour Island and Spanish Wells, off Eleuthera · 1695 to 1716

Two women at the north end of Eleuthera were brought to bed on the same day. One was a Sands, of Harbour Island, and her son was named Tobias. The other was an Albury, of Spanish Wells, two hours' sail to the westward, and her son was named Cornelius. The Sandses and the Alburys had been friends for three generations, since the night their grandfathers came in off the reef called the Devil's Backbone holding to the same spar, and when one house had a christening the other house cooked for it.

Each was the first family of its settlement, which in those islands meant a house with a board floor and a sloop. The men cut braziletto. It is a crooked, thorny tree, nothing to look at, and all its worth is inside it. The dyers in London want the heart, which is as red as a cut thumb. The white sapwood round the heart gives no color and nobody will pay freight on it. So a braziletto cutter spends his days chipping sap from heart with a hatchet, and by the time the two boys were ten years old they could do it by the sound.

They grew up in and out of each other's boats. Whatever there was to learn in the islands, piloting, turtling, raking salt, working a wreck, they had it sooner than other boys and had it better. When Tobias Sands put

out from Harbour Island every lad who could get away put out behind him, and it was the same with Cornelius Albury at Spanish Wells.

II. The Fair

Nassau, New Providence · 1716

In the summer of 1715 the Spanish plate fleet went ashore in a hurricane on the coast of Florida, eleven ships with the King of Spain's silver in them, and every sloop in the Bahamas went over to fish the wrecks. The fishing turned to taking. Those who took did not go home. A year later there were a thousand of them at Nassau, where there had been a hundred settlers and no governor, and the harbor was the merriest place in the Indies. A town of old sails stood along the beach, stretched over spars. There were fiddlers and punch houses and women from Jamaica. There was a man who sang the lament of Captain Kidd, all the verses. There was a great deal of silver, and it went from hand to hand like sand.

The two friends sailed over to see it, as the young men of all the out islands did. Room was made for them under the best awning, and for some days they saw the show as it was meant to be seen. When the company laughed, they laughed. When the singer came to the verse at Execution Dock, they wept with the rest. When the hat came round, they threw silver into it.

Then there came an evening when the fiddles struck up and there was nothing in it for either of them. Tobias sat and looked at the dancers. He thought: *There is not a man on this beach who will be above ground in twenty years, and most of them not in five. What is there here to look at? I ought to be looking for the thing that keeps.*

Cornelius said, *You are not merry, as you were the other nights. What is in your mind?*

I was thinking that none of this keeps. I mean to go and find what does. And you? You are as glum as I am.

I have been sitting here thinking the same thing.

Then we have had one good thought between us, said Tobias. *We will look together. Who shall we go to?*

The great man of the harbor that season was Captain Solomon Jayne, who had a ship of twenty guns and a hundred and forty hands, and the name of a deep man. *We will go to Jayne,* they said. They sent half the lads who had followed them home with the sloops, and went aboard with the other half. From the day those two signed his articles Jayne's fortunes ran high, for every young man in the islands wanted to be in the ship the Eleuthera men were in.

Jayne was no fool. He would not be pinned to anything. If a man asked him whether there was a reckoning after the rope, he would say, *I do not say there is. I do not say there is not. I do not say it is otherwise.* What he did hold he put in few words, and it was the creed of the whole harbor. Another captain of the trade was afterward set down in print as giving it so:

> *In an honest Service, says he, there is thin Commons, low Wages, and hard Labour; in this, Plenty and Satiety, Pleasure and Ease, Liberty and Power; and who would not ballance Creditor on this Side, when all the Hazard that is run for it, at worst, is only a sour Look or two at choaking. No, A merry Life and a short one, shall be my Motto.*
>
> *— Captain Charles Johnson, A General History of the Pyrates (1724)*

In a week the two friends had all of it, the ship and the guns and the taking and the sharing out. They went aft.

Captain, is this the whole of what you know, or is there something more?

That is the whole of it, said Jayne. *You have it all.*

III. Every Port

1716 and 1717

They talked it over on the forecastle. If that was all, there was nothing to stay for. But the sea was wide, and there were a good many men on it who had the name of knowing something. They would go round and ask.

They went in Jayne's ship while she served and in other bottoms when she did not. At Port Royal they sat with old men who had crossed the Isthmus behind Morgan. On the Mosquito shore they sat with a striker who could feed a hundred hands with one harpoon. They talked with a Spanish friar taken out of a prize, and with a ship's surgeon who had been to a university, and in Boston with a minister who came down to the jail to pray with men of their own trade before they were hanged. Whatever these people asked, the two friends could answer. What the two friends asked, nobody could. It was always the one question. *What keeps?*

After a year and a half they had been everywhere a keel would take them, and they came back to Nassau and to Jayne's ship, having found nothing. Before they turned in that night Tobias said, *Whichever of us comes on it first tells the other.* Cornelius gave his hand on it.

IV. Old Rope

Nassau · February 1718

WHILE THEY WERE GONE A SHIPWRIGHT HAD COME DOWN from Bermuda in a cedar sloop of his own building. His name was Jeremiah Darrell. He was an old man and a free man of color, forty years in the Bermuda yards, and it was said of him that he had once walked away from a good house and a wife and a young son, and had worked six years as no man ought to work, before he understood his trade. Now he kept a careening yard on the back of Hog Island, across the harbor from the town. He would heave down and clean a vessel for anybody and take his pay in whatever they had.

Men who went over to Hog Island to see a bottom cleaned did not always come back to their ships. Five came to him first, an old hand named Cundall before the others. Then a merchant's son from Charles Town with his friends, then thirty young wreckers in a body, then three long-haired brothers named Cash who had kept a turtlers' fire on a cay in the Exumas and brought their whole camp with them. Mr. Pinder, one of the

old settlers, who had a storehouse on the bay, gave the ground the yard stood on. By that winter above a hundred men worked there.

At the end of February His Majesty's ship *Phoenix* came in with the King's proclamation. Any pirate who gave himself up would be pardoned for everything done before. The harbor split down the middle over it, and for some days nobody talked of anything else.

On one of those mornings Tobias Sands, walking up from the water, saw a man going along the row of tents with a sack. He was begging old rope, the worn-out stuff that caulkers pick apart for oakum. He stopped at each tent and stood, and took what was handed out, and went on to the next. He kept his eyes on the ground a little way ahead of him. He did not hurry, and he did not look in.

Tobias had looked into a great many faces by then. He had never seen one with so little trouble in it. He thought, *That man has it, or he is on the road to it.* But a man at his work is not to be stopped with questions. So Tobias walked behind him at a few paces, the way a man does who wants a favor. When the caulker had his sack full and looked about for a place to sit and eat, Tobias fetched his own keg from the boat and set it down for him in the shade, and when he had eaten gave him water from his own jar.

Friend, he said then, *your face is easy and your eye is clear. Whose man are you? What does he hold by?*

I am the old man's on Hog Island. But I am new in the yard. I have not been long at it, and I could not lay it out for you at any length.

Say little or say much, said Tobias, *but give me the heart of it. The heart is all I want. What would I do with a great many words?*

Then it is this. Whatever rots, he will show you where the water got in.

Tobias stood still. He had carried one question to every port between Newfoundland and Campeche, and here was the answer, in a dozen words, from a man with a sack of junk. He knew it for the answer all the way through before the man had finished.

And he says: keep the water out, and there the rot stops.

That is enough, said Tobias. *Do not tell me more. Go on ahead of me. I have a friend, and I gave him my word.* He stood with his hat in his hand until the man with the sack had gone on up the beach.

Cornelius saw him coming a long way off. *That is not the face you went out with this morning,* he said. *You have come on it.*

I have come on it, said Tobias, and gave him the words as he had got them, and before he had done Cornelius had it too.

Where is he?

Hog Island.

Then let us go over.

But it was a way Tobias had all his life, that he would never slight anyone who had taught him anything. *We will tell Jayne first,* he said. *He has been our captain. He may see it. If he does not see it he may take our word, and come and hear for himself.*

V. The Water Butt

Aboard Jayne's ship · the same day

JAYNE WAS ON HIS QUARTERDECK. *WELL,* HE SAID. *IN ALL YOUR ports, did you find the man who could tell you what keeps?*

We have found him, Captain. He is across the harbor. And the King's pardon lies open on the beach for any man to walk in under. You are sailing empty. There is no heart in the timber. Come over with us.

You go. I cannot.

Why not?

I have been captain to a hundred and forty men. For me to go and be a hand in another man's yard would be the water butt going to the well for a dipper. I could not do it.

Do not take it that way, Captain.

Never mind. You go. I stay.

Captain, with the pardon come, every man in this harbor will be crossing to him. What will you do?

Tell me one thing. Which are there more of in this world, fools or wise men?

Fools, Captain. Wise men are few.

Then let the wise men go over to your wise carpenter, and let the fools come to me. I shall never want for a crew. Go on, the pair of you.

You will be a famous man, Captain, they said, and went down the side.

As they pulled for the beach the ship emptied behind them. Men dropped into the boats and men swam. Jayne stood and looked at his bare deck, and then he leaned over the rail and brought up blood, hot, out of his chest. A hundred and forty followed the two friends along the sand. At the table where the King's officer was taking names, seventy of them thought better of it, and turned round, and went back aboard. The other seventy gave their names and walked on behind the two to the ferrying place.

VI. Right Hand and Left

Darrell's yard, Hog Island

Darrell was sitting on a baulk of timber in the middle of the yard, with a sloop hove down on the sand in front of him, talking to his hands and to some of the townspeople who had rowed over to listen. He saw the boats while they were still small.

Here come two friends, he said. *Sands and Albury. Those two will be my right hand and my left.*

They came up the beach with their hats off. *Master, we would work under you, if you will have us.*

Come on, then, said Darrell. *The trade is plainly taught here. Work at it until there is an end of grief.*

The yard always held that by dark those two were going over the hull with adze and maul like men forty years out of their time, and that nobody could say where they had got the tools.

That same evening, when the hands sat down together, Darrell put Tobias on his right and Cornelius on his left, and said that these were his two mates, and what they said about the work he said.

The seventy who had come over with them had the trade through and through within days. The two friends were slower. Cornelius was a week at it, and on the seventh day was nodding over the pitch kettle when the

old man shook him awake and sat down beside him and took a ship to pieces for him in words, what in her was earth and what was water and what was fire and what was air, and by nightfall Cornelius had come to the end of it. Tobias took a fortnight. His sister's son, a lank young man who held with nothing, had come over from the town to dispute. *I hold with nothing, old man,* he said. *Do you hold with that?* said Darrell, and went on from there to speak of pleasure and pain and what is neither, and how a man who watches them come and go leaves off clutching. Tobias was standing behind with a palmetto fan, keeping the flies off the old man's neck. It was not said to him. He got his dinner, they said afterward, out of a pot put on for somebody else. As to why it took the quicker man longer, the yard had an answer for that too. A king's ship is longer getting to sea than a dory. There is more to stow.

But the seating was not liked. The hands talked of it by the fires.

It is favor. If he wanted mates, there was Cundall and the first five. If not them, the Charles Town men. If not them, the thirty, or the Cashes, who brought him a whole camp. He has passed over every one and taken the last two up the beach.

Darrell came by and asked what they were talking about, and they told him.

I have no favorites, he said. *Every man of you has had from me the thing he asked for, and so have they. Listen.*

He told them about Cundall, things Cundall had half forgotten. As a young man he had planted corn with his elder brother on the Eleuthera main, in a year when a preacher and his people were going hungry on that shore. He bit a kernel in the milk one morning and it was sweet, and he wanted to give the hungry people green corn. His brother said nobody had ever given away corn green, it would ruin the crop, and if he must be a fool he could be one on his own half. So they ran a line down the field. From his half Cundall gave the first of the ears in the milk, and the first of the ripe ears, and the first at the cutting, and the first in the shock; the first at the husking, and in the crib, and at the shelling, and from the mortar, and the first bread. That was nine times from one crop. Each time he looked again, his half stood as full as before. *And each time they*

thanked him and asked what he would have for it, he said one thing: when what is worth knowing comes by, let me be the first to know it. He did not ask to be anybody's mate. He was the first man into this yard and the first who saw what I was about. That is Cundall, paid in full.

The Charles Town men, in the yellow fever year, had carried the poor dead out to burial when their own kin would not touch them. One was a woman near her time. Young Yates, laying her in the ground, saw what a body is, and showed his four friends, and they went back and told the rest. They had asked only to see it as it is. So one night in his father's fine house Yates saw it a second time, and got up and walked out, and kept walking until he came here. The thirty had been thieves, and had once overheard a piece of good advice that was meant for a hog on its way to the knife, and had kept it better than the hog's owner did. They had asked to be done with thieving. They were done.

As for the Cashes, that is an older business, said Darrell, and he told them the tale Eleuthera tells about the winter after the reef. The company were in the cave with nothing saved. Three brothers who had got a little ashore gave all of it to feed the preacher and the people for three months, and put the serving out of it under a storekeeper and his men. The storekeeper's children cried, and he fed them first out of the common pot. Then he fed his own people first. In the end he and his men were eating the best of it themselves, behind the rock, and the company had what was left. *The three brothers asked to be free men one day and they are. The storekeeper's people have been hungry ever since. Ask Mr. Pinder.*

Mr. Pinder was the storekeeper's grandson, and he told it himself. The night after he first gave a dinner to the yard, there was a noise round his house that he would not care to hear again, and when he looked out there were people standing at the wall, as thin as lath. He went over to Hog Island in the morning. *They are your kin,* Darrell told him. *They stand outside the wall and at the gate post and where the roads cross. They come back to their own house, and there is plenty on the table, and nobody remembers them. They have asked every honest man who passed this way when they might eat, and each one told them, not in my time. Give the dinner again, and say it is for them.* Pinder gave it and said so. The next night they stood at the wall

again, filled out, and stark naked. *You gave them no clothes,* said Darrell. So Pinder gave every man in the yard a shirt and trousers in their name, and they were not seen at his wall any more.

Now, Sands and Albury, said Darrell. *The same winter, the same cave. Somebody had to go for help, and there was one small boat, stove in. The carpenter mended her on the open beach, seven days in the sun. The first Sands on this island stood by him those seven days holding a palmetto thatch over his head, and did not go off to eat. He was watching the carpenter's mate, who had each tool in the carpenter's hand before it was asked for. When the boat was done the carpenter asked what he would have. He said, I do not want land and I do not want a share. Some day let me, or one of mine, be to such a man what your mate is to you. Then he went and told his friend, the first Albury, and Albury fed the boatbuilders seven days and asked for the second place. It has been seventy years coming in. I did not give it to them. They asked for it. I give each man what he asked.*

VII. Heart and Sap

The same evening

WHEN HE HAD DONE, THE TWO FRIENDS STOOD UP, AND TOLD the yard the rest: the fair, and the evening the fiddles went dead, and Jayne, and every port, and the man with the sack. Then they told what Jayne had said on his quarterdeck, about the water butt and the dipper, and about the fools.

Darrell listened to the end. There was a billet of braziletto in the firewood by his foot, with the bark on, and he turned it over with his toe so that the cut end showed, the red in the middle and the white ring round it.

Jayne has taken the sap for the heart, he said, *and he looks at heart and calls it sap. A man who cuts that way never comes to the heart at all. He goes where his wanting takes him, and it takes him wrong.*

You two knew heart for heart and sap for sap. You were bred to it. So you chipped off what was nothing and kept what was something, and you have come to the heart. Your wanting was sound, and it brought you in.

A good many who sat by the fires that night, hands and townspeople both, got up from them changed.

• • •

Jayne slipped out by the eastern passage with his seventy before the Governor came, and he was a famous man for the better part of two years.

In the morning there was a plank to come out by the sternpost of the sloop on the sand. It looked well enough under the paint. Tobias Sands went along it with the point of his knife until the knife went in to the handle, and found the place above it where the water had been getting in, and Cornelius Albury went up the beach for the cedar.

Background

The verses

> *They who imagine truth in untruth, and see untruth in truth, never arrive at truth, but follow vain desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 11, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *They who know truth in truth, and untruth in untruth, arrive at truth, and follow true desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 12, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The word Müller renders "truth" is *sāra*, the pith or heartwood of a tree. In the commentary, Upatissa and Kolita, sons of the leading families of two neighboring villages and friends from birth, lose their taste for a hilltop festival and go looking for what does not die. They exhaust the teaching of the skeptic Sañjaya, wander all India questioning teachers, and agree that whoever finds the deathless first will tell the other. Upatissa meets the monk Assaji on his alms round and is won by a two-line summary: of things that arise from a cause, the Buddha has told the cause, and their ceasing. Sañjaya refuses to go with them (a great jar, he says, cannot become a dipper; let the wise go to Gotama and the many fools come to him), and half his following leaves. The Buddha names the two his chief disciples, Sāriputta and Moggallāna, the same day. When older monks complain of favoritism he tells what each of them once wished for: the giver of first fruits nine times, the friends who buried the poor, the three brothers whose stewards ate the monks' food and became hungry ghosts until a kinsman's gift fed and clothed them, and the two friends themselves, one of

whom long ago held a canopy of flowers over a Buddha for seven days. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta and Moggallāna.

Nassau, New Providence, Bahamas

Nassau, 1715 to 1718

The Eleutheran Adventurers, about seventy Puritan Independents from Bermuda, were wrecked on the Devil's Backbone reef off north Eleuthera around 1648 and sheltered in what is still called Preacher's Cave; their leader went for help to Virginia in a small boat. Their descendants on Harbour Island and at Spanish Wells lived by wrecking, turtling, salt and dyewood, above all braziletto, whose red heartwood was the only part the dyers bought. After a hurricane wrecked the Spanish treasure fleet on the Florida coast in July 1715, the salvagers and raiders it drew made ungoverned Nassau their base, the so-called Republic of Pirates: by one governor's count more than a thousand pirates beside about a hundred settlers. Vessels were hove down for cleaning on the harbor beaches and on Hog Island, now Paradise Island.

George I's proclamation of pardon reached Nassau in force with Captain Vincent Pearse of HMS *Phoenix* in February 1718. Pearse listed 209 men who said they would take it, fewer than half of those on the island, and the pirate company split between those who came in and those, like Charles Vane, who sailed out when Governor Woodes Rogers arrived that July. The creed in the second section is given to Bartholomew Roberts in Captain Charles Johnson's General History of the Pyrates (1724). Jayne, Darrell, his yard and everyone in it are invented, and the three tales of the winter in the cave are told here as island legend, not as record. Bermuda's cedar sloops, and the free and enslaved Black shipwrights who built many of them, were the best regarded in those waters.

After the story of the Chief Disciples from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 11 and 12). The original. The pirate's creed is from Captain Charles Johnson, A General History of the Pyrates (1724); the teaching is in the teacher's own words. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

1.9

Beat In the Reed

> *The iuster ye driue it, the smoother and plaine,*
> *more handsome ye make it to shut off the raine.*
> *— Thomas Tusser, Fiue Hundred Pointes of Good Husbandrie (1580)*

Thus it was told me, on the north bank of the James.

I. The Cup

Chalk, by Gravesend, Kent · April 1618

Ned Fenn was a reed thatcher, the son and grandson of reed thatchers, and at twenty-three he had the name of the best hand between Gravesend and the Medway. On the Tuesday after Easter three things came to him in one day. His uncle, old Mr. Lyle, who had raised him, made over to him the tools and the custom of the trade. He was to sleep that night for the first time under a roof of his own, a cottage of two rooms at the marsh end of Chalk, which he had built through the winter and thatched with reed of his own cutting. And at nine in the morning he married Joan Barrow, whom the whole parish called the Fair Maid of Kent, after the old princess, and nobody in the parish thought the name too much for her.

His cousin came to the wedding. Thomas Lyle was the old man's only son, twelve years older than Ned, and when Ned was small he had followed Thomas about the marsh the way a dog follows a cart. Thomas had gone up to Cambridge and taken orders and buried a young wife. Now he was going out as minister to a new plantation in Virginia, and his ship lay off Gravesend that same morning, waiting on the searchers and the ebb.

He came over the fields in his black coat. He ate bride-cake standing in Ned's new doorway, and looked up at the roof, and said it was a good roof. Under his arm he had a small silver communion cup in a case of boiled leather, which he would not trust to the hold of a ship. When he had wished them joy he put the case into Ned's hands, as a man does who wants both his own free, and kissed Joan on the forehead, and went out of the door and down the lane without it.

Ned stood holding the cup. It was not a thing to shout after a man about, like a hat. He said to Joan, *He will want it at the gate,* and went after him.

Thomas did not turn at the gate. He walked like a man with a tide to catch. Ned thought, *At the lane's end.* At the lane's end his cousin did not put out a hand. Ned thought, *At the church stile,* and then, *At the top of the town,* and then, *At the stairs.* He had known since he was four years old that you did not pluck Thomas Lyle by the sleeve. He was a bridegroom in his wedding hose, a mile from his bride, carrying the vessel of the Sacrament through Gravesend on a market morning, and he could not find the place to stop.

At the head of the water stairs he heard her. Somebody had run to tell her that the parson was walking off with her husband, and Joan had come the whole mile as she was, with half her hair braided up for the day and the other half down her back. She stood at the top of the stairs with one hand on the post.

Ned, she said. *Come back soon.*

It went through him like cold water. He stood on the wet steps with the cup. His cousin was already seated in the wherry and had not once looked round, and the waterman was holding the boat to the stair with one oar and looking at Ned to learn whether he was coming. Ned thought, *At the ship's side, then,* and stepped in.

At the ship's side Thomas went up the ladder, and Ned went up after him to put the cup into his hand on the deck. On the deck the anchor was coming home and the pilot was shouting, and Thomas turned to him at last and said, *Ned, will you come to Virginia?*

He did not want to go to Virginia. He wanted to be in the cottage at the marsh end under his own reed. But he had never in his life said no to that face, and he found he could not begin now, on a ship's deck, with the cup in his hands.

Aye, he said. *I'll come.*

Then enter him, said Thomas to the purser, and Edmund Fenn of Chalk was written down a tenant of the Company for seven years.

II. The Portion

Gravesend stairs · the same tide

THOMAS LYLE HAD A SON, RAFE, SEVEN YEARS OLD, WHOM THE grandfather kept. The boy's nurse had dressed him that morning in his best and walked him down to the water and pointed. *That is your father, in the black coat. He is going over the sea, and he has not left you so much as a spoon. Go and ask him for your portion.*

The boy went down the stairs and into the next boat as if it had been sent for him. He came up the ship's ladder behind Ned and took hold of his father's coat and said, *It is pleasant standing by you, sir.* Then he said, *Father, give me my portion,* and when Thomas walked aft he walked aft behind him, saying it. The sailors could not get him off the coat, and Thomas did not shake him off.

Thomas looked at the boy a good while. Whatever there was to leave him in England would be spent, or would spoil him. He said to the mate, *Let him stay. I will give him a portion that does not waste,* and the boy was entered too.

So old Mr. Lyle, who had walked down behind the rest with his stick, stood at the head of Gravesend stairs beside a girl with her hair half braided, and watched his son and his nephew and his grandson go down the river on one ebb. He was a man who seldom asked for anything. He wrote that night, and the letter went by the next ship, and there was one request in it: that his son would never again carry any man's child over the sea unless the father and the mother had both said yes.

Thomas wrote back that he would not, and he kept to it. In the years after, ships brought out children by the hundred, taken up off the London streets by the constables and bound to the Company, and planters stood at the landing to receive them. The minister of Mereworth Hundred would never put his name to one.

III. New Ground

Mereworth Hundred, on the James · 1618 and 1619

THE HUNDRED WAS SOME FORTY MEN AND SIX WOMEN, A PALISade, a storehouse, and a church that was a tobacco barn with a table in it, on the north bank a day's row above James City. Behind it the new ground ran back into the woods. It had been cleared the way the people of the country cleared theirs: the great trees ringed with a hatchet and left to die standing, the brush burned, and corn and tobacco hilled up among the black stumps.

Across the river and above were the towns of the Weyanock, who had planted that shore longer than anyone could say. There had been four years of peace. Weyanock men came into the hundred with venison to trade, and went about looking into the English houses with the plain interest of people seeing how strangers live.

In the first summer a third of the newcomers died of the fluxes and the burning fever, which the old hands called the seasoning. Ned lived. The boy Rafe lived, and carried the cup in its case behind his father to every sickbed, and was not heard to ask for his portion again.

Ned was set to roofs. There was reed in plenty along the creeks, taller and coarser than Thames reed, and he cut it and carried it, and by Christmas he had roofed the storehouse, the church and nine cabins. Every one of them leaked. It was the talk of the hundred. A man who knew the trade could have told why: the courses were laid slack, the reed was not driven home, the ridge was skimped. Ned knew the trade. He would be up the ladder with a bundle under his arm and the legget in his hand, and he would be standing at the head of Gravesend stairs. He would be counting weeks. So many out, so many home, and she had said soon. Rain

came through his roofs as it comes through a hedge, and men lay in the wet and cursed the Kentish thatcher and his cousin with him.

In the spring he said it out before a dozen of them in the storehouse.

I am sick of it. I cannot bear another season of it. When the ship goes home I mean to go in her, term or no term, and they may do what they like with me at the other end.

It was no small thing to say aloud. No bound man left Virginia without the Governor's pass, and men had been whipped there for less than the wish.

The minister had it within the hour, and sent for him.

Is it true, Ned, what you said before them all?

It is true, sir.

Why?

When I left my house, sir, Joan stood at the head of the stairs with her hair half up, and she said, Come back soon. I hear it. I am on the ladder and I hear it. That is the whole of it.

Thomas took him by the arm, above the elbow, and walked him out by the land gate into the new ground.

It had been burned over that week for planting, and the ash was still warm. At the far side, on a burnt oak stump, sat a she-raccoon that the fire had caught. The people of the country called the creature aroughcun: a thing the bigness of a cat, with hands like a child's. This one's ears were burned off, and her tail, and the end of her nose. She sat on the black stump with a charred ear of last year's corn in her two hands, gnawing at it, and she would not leave it though they came within a rod of her.

Mark her, said Thomas, and walked on.

What came next Ned told the same way all his life, and would not be argued out of it. His cousin still had him by the arm. They went in under the standing timber at the edge of the clearing, and it was a great deal farther through than it had any right to be, and then they were up. That was his word for it. He never said heaven. It was a wide court, he said, paved with stone, with a light on it like the light on the river at five of a summer morning, and at the upper end some great lord kept his state, whose face Ned did not see. Waiting on that lord were maids. Five hun-

dred, he said, though he owned he had not counted. They went barefoot on the pavement, and their feet were pink as a dove's feet. He stood looking at them as he had stood with the cup that morning in Chalk, not knowing where to stop.

Ned, said Thomas. *Which is the fairer, your Joan or these?*

And Ned Fenn, who was an honest man, and was sorry to hear it come out of his own mouth, said, *Sir, as that burnt thing on the stump is to Joan, so is Joan to these. She does not come into the count. Not a part of it. Not a part of a part.*

Then be easy, said Thomas. *Do the work you were brought here to do, and I stand surety that you shall have them. The five hundred.*

If you stand surety for that, sir, said Ned, *I will stay, and gladly.*

Then they were in the new ground again with the ash warm under their shoes, and the raccoon was still at her corn.

IV. Wages

Mereworth Hundred · 1619 to 1621

It could not be kept, and Ned was no man to keep it. He went about for a week with his mouth open. Before the corn was up, every soul in Mereworth knew that the thatcher was staying for wages, that the parson had gone bail for them, and what the wages were.

They did not let it lie. There were men in the hundred who had come for land, and men who had come because a justice gave them the choice, and two or three who would have said, if you pressed them, that they had come for God. Not one of them had come for five hundred barefoot maids. They called him the hireling. They called him the bought man. *Good morrow, Ned, and how do your wages?* It was said at the storehouse door and across the church. He was despised for it, and he knew that he was, and he could not say they were wrong.

He stopped talking. He went to the work, since the work was the condition; and because nobody now would hand reed up to him, he did it alone.

He began by stripping the church. He had the whole slack roof off and on the ground, and he stood and looked at it, and saw it for what it was, the work of a man who had been somewhere else.

Then he crossed the river. He had watched the Weyanock men look into the English houses, and look up, and say nothing, and he wanted to see what they looked up at when they were at home. The houses of the Weyanock town were long and round-backed. The women built them. They were covered with mats of sewn rush, or with bark taken from the tree in sheets and laid so close, each over the next, that nothing could get between. Ned stood inside one through an afternoon of rain, with the fire burning on the floor and the smoke going out at the top, and no drop came in.

A woman of that town, old enough to have been his mother, saw what he was looking at. She had no English and he had nothing of her tongue. She took up a mat she was mending and showed him with her hands how the rushes all lay one way, and how near together the stitches were set, and she had him pull at it. He thanked her as well as a man can with his cap. He went back four or five times that year, and he cut rush for her when he went.

He roofed the church again, by himself, through the autumn. He laid each course and beat it up with the legget until the butts stood as even as a planed board, and pinned it down, and went on to the next. When his mind went off to Gravesend stairs he would find that his hand had gone slack with it, and he pulled out the last armful and laid it again. Later it was not the stairs. It was the paved court and the feet. That slacked his hand the same, and he pulled that out too. In time he found there was no thought of that kind, about any woman or any place, that did not let the water in somewhere.

It took him the better part of two years to go over every roof in the hundred. By the end he could lay reed for a whole day with nothing in him but the reed. One evening in the second autumn he was on the ridge of the last cabin with the light going, and he looked in himself for the wanting, as a man feels with his tongue for a sore tooth. It was gone. He tried Joan, and the cottage, and the ship home, and the five hundred, one

after another, and there was nothing to any of them. He sat on the ridge a while longer. Then he came down the ladder and put his tools away dry.

The sexton said afterward that there was a light in the church that night, and no candle that he could find, and nobody there. Thomas Lyle sat up late in his house as if he expected someone. Toward midnight Ned knocked.

Sir, he said. *That surety you stood for me. I release you from it.*

I knew at dusk, said Thomas. *And I was quit of it the same hour. The moment you stopped wanting them, Ned, I was out of my bond.*

V. The Maids

Mereworth Hundred · December 1621

The year before, the Company in London had sent over ninety young women to make wives for the planters, so that the men might be more settled and less ready to go home. Now it sent fifty-seven more. The first of them came in the *Marmaduke* before Christmas, chosen with extraordinary care, the Company wrote, and a man who wanted one must first win her consent and then pay the Company a hundred and fifty pounds of best leaf for her passage. Every man in Mereworth who had the leaf got ready to go down to James City by boat.

Some of them came round by the thatcher first, for the sport. Ned had tobacco hanging. He had been paid in it for two years of roofs.

Here are your wages come up the river at last, Ned, said one, *and only a hundred and fifty weight the head. Will you go down with us?*

No, said Ned.

Two years back you stood in the storehouse and said, I am sick of it, I cannot bear it. Do you say so now?

No. I have no mind that way at all. Nor back to Kent either.

They did not believe him. A man who had stayed for five hundred would hardly turn up his nose at one. They went to the minister in a body and told him the thatcher was a liar.

Thomas heard them out. Then he walked them across to the church and stood them in front of it, and made them look at the roof they sat un-

der every Sunday and had stopped noticing on the day it stopped wetting them.

You remember his first roofs, he said. *The rain went through them where it liked. That was the man then. This is the man now. He has had the rule of it by heart since he was a boy, and so have half of you.*

> *Where houses be reeded (as houses haue neede),*
> *now pare off the mosse, and go beat in the reed.*
> *The iuster ye driue it, the smoother and plaine,*
> *more handsome ye make it to shut off the raine.*
>
> *— Thomas Tusser, Fiue Hundred Pointes of Good Husbandrie (1580), Maies husbandrie*

A mind is roofed the same way, said Thomas. *Lay it slack, and wanting comes through it as rain comes through bad thatch. Drive it home, and wanting does not come through. From the day he saw those maids he has been beating in the reed, and now he has done. Let him alone.*

That night a few of them were still turning it over by the storehouse fire. It was a strange thing in a parson, they said, to bait a man along with women.

Thomas said it was nothing new with Ned. It was the potter's ass over again.

There was a potter of Aylesford who took his ass to Rochester market under a load of pots. While he sold, the ass strayed along the ditch and fell in with a she-ass. Where are you from? Aylesford. On what errand? Pots. How far do you carry them? Seven miles. And at the end of the seven miles, is there anyone to rub your legs and your back? No. Then yours is a hard life, she said. Nobody has ever rubbed an ass's legs. She said it to be friendly.

When the potter came for him, the ass would not stir. The potter said, I will cut a goad with a thorn in it as long as my hand. The ass said, Do, and I will plant my forefeet and let fly with the hind ones and have your teeth out. The potter looked about him and saw the jenny. So he said, I will bring you home one like her, grey, with a white muzzle, to be your own. And the ass said, Then I will go fourteen miles a day.

A week after, the ass asked where his wife was. The potter said, I keep my word. But I feed one ass. The hay I give you may do for two or it may not; you must settle that between you. And there will be foals. Whether it does for them as well, you must settle that too. The ass thought about his manger, and lost his stomach for a wife.

The men who had been down to James City laughed less at this than the men who had not.

And which was the potter? one of them asked.

Thomas said he had been a potter in his time.

• • •

It rained that night, the cold, steady rain that country has in December, on the church and the storehouse and the nine cabins, and in the morning every floor in Mereworth was dry.

Ned sent one letter to Chalk, by the ship that carried the maids' tobacco home. He gave the cottage at the marsh end, and the tools, and her promise back again, to Joan Barrow, to keep or to part with as she pleased. He asked only that whoever had the house should go up in May and pare the moss off.

Background

The verses

> *As rain breaks through an ill-thatched house, passion will break through an unreflecting mind.*
>
> Dhammapada 13, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *As rain does not break through a well-thatched house, passion will not break through a well-reflecting mind.*
>
> Dhammapada 14, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Nanda is the Buddha's half-brother, the son of his mother's sister. On the day of Nanda's consecration, house-warming and wedding, the Buddha puts his alms bowl into Nanda's hands and walks away, and Nanda, too respectful to call after him, follows with it all the way to the monastery while his bride, her hair

half combed, begs him to come back soon. He is ordained against his wish. The Buddha's small son Rāhula follows too, asking for his inheritance, and is ordained, and the grieving grandfather obtains the rule that no child be ordained without his parents' leave. Nanda pines and means to leave, so the Buddha shows him a singed monkey on a burnt stump, then five hundred dove-footed nymphs in the heaven of the Thirty-Three, and guarantees him the nymphs if he will stay. The monks call him a hireling. He practises alone, becomes an arahat, and releases the Buddha from the promise. The Buddha then tells how, in an earlier life, the same Nanda was a balky donkey won over by the promise of a mate. Read the full commentary story, or about Nanda.

James River, Virginia

The James River, 1618 to 1621

After 1617 the Virginia Company granted large tracts along the James to private groups of investors, who settled them as "hundreds" or particular plantations, each expected to bring its own people and its own minister. Mereworth Hundred and everyone in it are invented; Berkeley Hundred, founded in 1619 on the same reach of the river, is a real one. Company tenants served seven years. New arrivals died in great numbers in their first summer, and the Company and the City of London shipped out poor children taken from the London streets, beginning with a hundred in 1619. The English built in wattle and thatch, and from their first years on the river also learned from their neighbors to cover houses with bark. The Weyanock were one of the peoples of the Powhatan paramount chiefdom, with towns on both banks of the James; among the Powhatan the women built the houses and made the mats. The peace that followed the marriage of Pocahontas in 1614 ended on March 22, 1622, three months after this story closes, when Opechancanough's forces struck the plantations that had spread along the river and killed about 347 colonists. The verse is by Thomas Tusser, the East Anglian farmer-poet whose rhymed calendar of farm work went through edition after edition from 1557 and was got by heart in country households. A reed thatcher's bat, for driving the butts of the reed up even, is still called a legget.

In 1619 the Company resolved to send young women "to make wives" for the planters, hoping that men with families would stop thinking of Virginia as a place to leave. About ninety came in 1620 and fifty-seven more were sent in 1621, some of them in the *Marmaduke*; the Company claimed "extraordinary care and diligence in the choice of them," required that each be free to choose her husband, and asked 150 pounds of good leaf tobacco from the man she chose, to cover her passage and outfit. They are remembered as the tobacco brides. The National Park Service has more on women at Jamestown.

After the story of the Elder Nanda from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 13 and 14). The original. Verse from Thomas Tusser, Fiue Hundred Pointes of Good Husbandrie (the edition of 1580, English Dialect Society reprint, 1878). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

1.10

The Slats

Thine own wickedness shall correct thee, and thy backslidings shall reprove thee
— Jeremiah 2:19

Zo heb ik het gehoord, in Sioux County.

I. Fifty-Five Years

Sioux County, Iowa · 1954–2008

Gerrit Brink killed his first hog in the fall of 1954, when he was eighteen, in his father's locker plant on the main street of town, where farm families rented a frozen-food locker by the year and brought in their own steer or hog to be cut and wrapped and labeled in grease pencil, and he killed his last one fifty-five years later in the machine shed behind his house on the gravel road east of Hull. In between he killed more hogs than anybody could count, though people in the county tried. When the locker closed in the seventies, because the big plants in Sioux City and Sioux Falls could do it cheaper, Gerrit put up a confinement barn on the home place and then another, and kept killing at home on the side, for anybody who wanted a hog done cheap and did not want to watch.

Everybody in that part of the county had a story about how he did it. He did not stun them right. He did not care to. He drove them out of the pen with a length of steel pipe and beat them along the alley to make them run, because he said a hog that had been run bled out better and the meat came up red. He hung them by a hind leg off the hoist and stuck them while they were still kicking, and he caught the blood in a dishpan, and his wife made blood sausage with it, the old way. He ran his scald

tank hotter than he needed to and sometimes put them into it before they were done. The Mexican boys who worked for him the summer of 1998 quit in a body after two weeks, and one of them said in the café in Hull, in front of everybody, that he had worked in the packing plant in Worthington and never seen a man do what that man did.

Gerrit had been baptized at First Reformed and made profession of faith at sixteen, and after that, as far as anybody knew, he never set foot in the church again. He did not tithe. He did not give to the mission auction or the disaster fund or the hospital. He worked on Sunday, which in Sioux County was a thing people still noticed, loading on the Lord's Day with the yard light on so the whole section could see. He did not send his boy to the Christian school, though he could have paid the tuition ten times over, and though the woman who had taught first grade there for forty-one years lived directly across the gravel from him.

Her name was Jantje Rozeboom. She had taught half the men in the county to read, and their children, and some of their grandchildren, and she was eighty-four. She had never married. She lived in her parents' house across the road from the Brinks and kept a garden and drove to church twice every Sunday in a Buick she had bought new in 1987. On summer evenings she sat on the porch, and from the porch she could see straight down Gerrit's driveway to the door of the machine shed, and hear what came out of it. People brought her things all year. Rhubarb and eggs and a quarter of beef, a pie at Christmas from a girl she had taught in 1962, a load of firewood every October from boys who were grandfathers now, who stacked it in her shed and would not take a dollar for it. She gave most of it away again. In forty years Gerrit Brink never once crossed the road. He did not take her a pound of sausage at Christmas or an ear of sweet corn in August, and he did not wave.

She had been a quiet teacher. She did not raise her voice, and she did not use the paddle the principal kept in his office for the purpose. When a child in her room did something cruel, she had one thing she did. In the spring of 1951 Arend Hulstein, who was seven, brought down a barn swallow with a slingshot in the schoolyard at noon recess and carried it in by one wing to show the other boys. Miss Rozeboom took it from him

and laid it on a clean handkerchief on the corner of his desk, and he sat with it there the whole afternoon, through arithmetic and reading and the closing prayer, with its blue back and its rust-colored throat and its eye half open, and she did not say one word to him about it. At three o'clock she let him bury it by the flagpole. Fifty-eight years later he could still have told you how many feathers were in its tail.

II. Swine Flu

Spring 2009

That April the news came out of Mexico about the new flu. Within a week the television was calling it swine flu, and it did not matter how many times the men from the pork board and the Department of Agriculture went on the air to say you could not catch it from a hog or a pork chop. People quit buying pork. China and Russia shut their doors to it. Hog prices, which had already been under water a year because the ethanol plants had run the price of corn up and feed had nearly doubled, fell through the floor.

By June there were men in that county losing twenty dollars and more on every hog they shipped. Some of them had been in hogs three generations. Some of them sat up nights at the kitchen table with a calculator and the paper from the bank. Young men who had built barns on borrowed money in 2006 called around to see if anybody would take their feeder pigs, because they could not afford the corn to finish them.

Gerrit Brink took them. He drove his gooseneck from one farm to the next all that summer and took weaned pigs off men's hands for five and ten dollars a head, and some for nothing, from a few who just wanted them gone. He took them from the sons of men he had gone to grade school with.

Kevin Den Hartog was twenty-nine and had built a nursery barn on his grandfather's eighty in 2006, when the bank was glad to lend on hogs. In July he had nine hundred weaned pigs in it, eating corn he could not pay for, and a buyer in Minnesota who had backed out. Gerrit pulled into his yard on a Tuesday afternoon with the gooseneck and did not get out of

the truck. He rolled down the window and named a price. Kevin said that would not pay for the vaccine. Gerrit said then Kevin could keep them, and put the truck in gear, and Kevin's wife came out on the step with the baby on her hip and watched the two of them, and Kevin said all right. Gerrit backed up to the chute and they loaded until dark. Some of the smallest ones went down in the trailer and got stepped on, and Gerrit said those were Kevin's loss, not his, and paid him for the count that came off alive at the other end.

He filled the old barn behind his house, the one he had stopped using in the nineties, with pigs nobody wanted. The fans in it had half quit and the pit under the slats had not been pumped in two years. He fed them on spoiled distillers' grain he got cheap from the ethanol plant, and on bakery waste, and on whatever else. In August the smell of that barn lay across the road on Miss Rozeboom's porch like a wet blanket, and she sat out in it anyway in the evenings, shelling peas. When people said to his face that it was a hard thing to do to a neighbor, he said he was only doing what the neighbor asked.

That fall, when the price came back some, he killed them in the shed and sold the meat for cash, or sold them live off the farm to the Mexican and Laotian families from the packing towns who wanted a whole hog for a party. Then he had them all, the meat and the money and the barn.

He killed through October, Saturdays and Sundays both, because Sunday was when the families could come. They drove up from Storm Lake and Sioux City in vans with the children in the back, and stood at the door of the machine shed in their good clothes, and some of them went back to the vans after the first one. From her porch Miss Rozeboom could hear it on a still afternoon. She did not go inside. She sat with her hands in her lap and her eyes open and listened to every one of them until it was done, and then she went in and washed her supper dishes.

Wes had grown up with it. When he was small his father used to make him hold the dishpan. He was forty-four now, with a family and a quarter section of his own two miles west, and he had not stood in that shed in twenty years, and he came over less every year, and every year he did not say why.

III. The Slats

November 2009

The stroke took him in the machine shed on a Thursday morning, standing over the scald tank. His son Wes found him on the concrete by the drain. The doctor in Orange City said it had not been a bad one, as strokes went, and sent him home on Saturday with pills and a walker.

On Saturday night he started to see the fire.

He sat up in the bed and told Alida the barn was burning. She went to the window. The barns were dark under the yard light, the way they always were. He said not that barn. He said the floor. He said he was standing on the slats and they had gone red under his feet, the whole floor of the barn red-hot, all the way out, farther than a barn went, farther than the section, for miles, and under the slats the pit was boiling. He said there was no end to it. He said he could not get off it. Alida called Wes, and Wes came over from his own place and sat up with him, and Gerrit talked about the slats until it got light.

He was not raving. That was what frightened Wes. His father talked about the fire the way he talked about the price of corn, in the same flat voice, as if it were a thing anybody could see who bothered to look, and he described it exactly: how far it went, the color of it under the slats, the sound the pit made boiling, the heat coming up through the soles of his feet. Toward morning he stopped in the middle of a sentence and looked past Wes at the wall, and said, *They're all here.*

Who is, Dad?

All of them. Every one. They're standing on it with me. And then, very quietly, as if he were counting, *Look at them. Look at them.*

On Sunday morning he got out of the bed onto his hands and knees.

He crawled through the house the way a hog goes down an alley, putting his head against the walls, nosing at the doors, from the kitchen to the front room and back to the kitchen, and the sounds he made were hog sounds. Grunting, and then the long high sound a hog makes when it is down in the pen and cannot get up. Alida screamed at him to stop. Wes

got hold of him and wrestled him back onto the bed, and he was seventy-three and had had a stroke three days before, and Wes could not hold him down. They tried a towel over his mouth. He bit through it. He got loose and went back down onto the floor and crawled for the back door.

Alida had been married to him fifty-one years. She had cleaned his boots and washed his coveralls and stirred his blood into the sausage in the dishpan on the kitchen table every fall of her married life, and never once said a word against any of it, and now she stood in the doorway of her own front room in her housecoat and watched him go past her on his hands and knees with his face against the baseboard, and she said the Lord's Prayer out loud, over and over, until Wes took her into the kitchen and sat her down. They were afraid he would get out into the cold, or into the barns, or across the road. So Wes locked the doors and nailed a plank across the back one, and pulled the shades, and the two of them sat up in the kitchen in their coats in turns, with the lights on, and listened to him go back and forth through the house in the dark.

On Wednesday the minister came out from First Reformed, a young man from Michigan who had been there two years, and stood on the back step in the wind, and Wes talked to him through the door with the plank across it and would not open it. Wes called the doctor, who said bring him in, and Wes said he could not get him into the truck. The doctor said call the sheriff, then, and Wes said his father would not want the sheriff, and the doctor said what his father wanted was beside the point now, and Wes said he would think about it, and did not call.

IV. Seven Nights

The gravel road east of Hull · Sunday to Sunday

IT HAD BEEN A COLD, WET FALL, AND THE HARVEST WAS THE latest in years. That second week of November two-thirds of the corn in Iowa was still standing, and every man on that road was running his combine past midnight under the lights, trying to get it out before the snow. They would shut down at one or two in the morning and climb down out of the cab into the quiet, and hear it. Sound carries on that ground at

NIGHT, WITH NOTHING BETWEEN ONE FARMSTEAD AND THE next but a windbreak and the corn. That week nobody slept on the section. The Van Peurs, a half mile north, heard it through closed windows. The Hulstein boys, who had a sow unit on the next road over, went out at two in the morning with flashlights, thinking a sow had gotten loose and was down in the ditch with a broken leg. Mrs. Vander Berg, who was ninety and nearly deaf, called her daughter in Sioux Center to say something was screaming out there and would not stop. In the old Kooiker house on the corner, which the Hulsteins rented to the family of the man who ran their sow barn, Mrs. Ramírez got up and lit the candle under the picture of the Virgin of Guadalupe on her dresser and sat with it on the edge of the bed, and her children came in one after another in the dark and got into the bed with her, all four of them, and stayed there until it was light. There were seven houses within a mile and a half of the Brink place, and in all seven of them people lay awake.

Everybody had a guess. It was the dead of night, it went on hour after hour, it came from the Brink place, and it sounded like hogs. And everybody on that road knew what Gerrit Brink had in his old barn, and what he did in his shed, and that he did not keep the Lord's Day or any other.

On Sunday evening four men drove home together from the second service at First Reformed. Their wives had gone home after the morning service. These four went to both. They had been in first grade together in the fall of 1950, in Miss Rozeboom's room at the Christian school, and they were sixty-five now, and two of them were in hogs and one had been and one sold seed. They drove east on the gravel with the windows cracked, and when they came past the Brink place they heard it plain over the engine and the tires. The truck slowed. Nobody said anything for a while.

On a Sunday night, said Arend Hulstein, who was driving. *On a Sunday night, he's running hogs through that shed.*

He's been at it all week, said Bert Van Peursem. *Ask my wife. Every night since last Sunday.*

He's killing out that barn. Those pigs he got off the Den Hartog boy and the rest of them.

He's not killing them. Listen to it. You don't kill a hog that slow. He's doing something to them.

Seven nights, said Bert. *All those hogs. You'd think a man would have one thought for the animal. One. Fifty years of it, and not one.*

Across the road Miss Rozeboom's porch light was on, which it never was that late. They turned in. She was in her kitchen in her Sunday dress with her Bible on the table and the lamp on, and she let them in and sat them down at the oilcloth, four old men in their church coats, the way she had sat them down at a little table with a box of crayons in 1950. She had heard it all week. She had not slept either.

They told her what they thought.

She heard them out. Then she said, *He hasn't killed a hog since a week ago Thursday. He's not in the shed. He's in his own house. Wes came over this afternoon. Gerrit's been down on his hands and knees on his kitchen floor for a week, and that's him you hear. He thinks he's standing on the slats and the slats are on fire.*

Nobody at the table said anything.

The noise had stopped. They all heard it stop. The kitchen clock went on, and the furnace came on in the basement, and out across the road there was no sound at all.

After a while she said, *That's it, then. That's the end of it.* And a few minutes later Wes's pickup came out of the Brink drive with the headlights on and turned toward town.

V. The Teacher

Miss Rozeboom's kitchen · Sunday night, late

HER KITCHEN HAD NOT CHANGED SINCE THEIR MOTHERS SAT IN it. The same oilcloth with the little blue windmills, the same clock over the sink, the same calendar from the elevator in Hull. Arend Hulstein, who had been in hogs forty years himself, sat with his hands flat on the oilcloth.

Then he got it here, he said. *And he's going where he gets it there too.*

Yes, she said.

Arend looked at his hands. *I've run hogs through that sale barn in Rock Valley when I didn't care what shape they were in. I've had men work for me I knew were rough on them and I let it go because they were cheap.* He did not finish.

Miss Rozeboom said it did not matter whether a man wore a church coat or never had one on. A man who did not watch what he was doing paid for it in this life and in the next one, and the paying was nothing but seeing, finally, what he had done. She did not say more about it than that. She opened the Bible on the table to a place she did not have to look for, the old American Standard her father had read at that table, and put her finger on the line and read it to them the way she used to read to them at the end of the day, before the bell.

> *Thine own wickedness shall correct thee, and thy backslidings shall reprove thee: know therefore and see that it is an evil thing and a bitter, that thou hast forsaken Jehovah thy God, and that my fear is not in thee, saith the Lord, Jehovah of hosts.*
>
> *— Jeremiah 2:19*

Then she closed it.

Did you ever say anything to him? Bert asked. *Forty years across the road.*

He never asked me anything, she said. *You can't hand a man something across a road if he won't come over for it.* She got up and put the coffee on, because it was after ten and none of them was going to sleep.

• • •

Gerrit Brink was buried out of First Reformed on Thursday, because Alida asked and the minister would not say no to her. The four men were there. So was Miss Rozeboom, in the back, in the same Sunday dress.

Wes sold the barns that winter to an outfit from Sioux Falls. Before the trucks came for the last of the pigs in the old barn behind the house, he cut the hoist chain down off the beam in the machine shed and sold the scald tank for scrap.

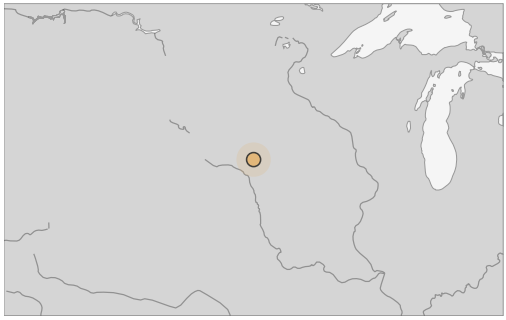
Arend Hulstein went home that Sunday night and did not go to bed. He put on his chore coat and walked out across his own yard to his own finishing barn, and let himself in, and stood in the alley with the lights turned low. Four hundred hogs lay on the slats in the warm dark, breathing, and the ones nearest the alley got up and came to the gates to look at him. He stood a long time with his hand on a gate, the way he had sat once at a desk with a handkerchief on the corner of it, and looked at them, and made himself see them, every one. After a while, one by one, they lay back down.

Background

The verse

> *The evil-doer mourns in this world, and he mourns in the next; he mourns in both.*
> *He mourns and suffers when he sees the evil of his own work.*
>
> Dhammapada 15, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Cunda makes his living for fifty-five years by killing pigs near the monastery where the Buddha lives. In famine years he trades a little rice in the villages for piglets and fattens them behind his house, and he kills them with deliberate cruelty, clubbing them and pouring boiling water down their throats. He never gives the Buddha so much as a handful of flowers or a spoonful of rice. When he falls ill, the fire of the Avīci hell rises up before him, and for seven days he crawls through his house grunting and squealing like a pig while his family keeps the doors barred and no one in the seven houses around can sleep. Monks passing by assume he is slaughtering pigs for a feast and say so to the Buddha, who tells them that Cunda has not been killing anything: his own deeds have overtaken him, he died that day, and he will suffer in the next world as he did in this one. Read the full commentary story.



Sioux County, Iowa

Sioux County, 2009

Dutch immigrants began arriving in Sioux County in northwest Iowa in 1869, and Dutch is still the most commonly reported ancestry there. The county's Reformed churches shape its life, and Sioux Center has been called the place with the most Dutch Americans in the country, though Mexican immigrants have come to do much of the hard work in town. It is also hog country. A 2020 study by the state's pork producers ranked Sioux County second in Iowa, with about 1.3 million hogs.

In April 2009 a new strain of H1N1 influenza was first identified in Mexico, and the press called it swine flu, though it passed from person to person and required no contact with pigs. China, Russia and more than a dozen other countries banned American pork. Hog farmers had already been losing money for a year as feed costs nearly doubled; the scare pushed prices down further, and economists estimated it cost the industry more than $900 million. That autumn was also one of the latest harvests in memory: as of November 8, only 34 percent of Iowa's corn had been harvested.

After the story of Cunda the pig butcher from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 15). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.11

The Izote

> *Yea, saith the Spirit, that they may rest from their labours; and their works do follow them.*
> *— Revelation 14:13*

Así lo oí contar, on Riggs Road.

I. The Sixteen

Hyattsville, Maryland · 1983–2017

José Alvarenga came up from Suchitoto in 1983 with a pair of work boots, a Bible with a cracked spine and the address of a cousin in Langley Park written on the inside of his wrist in ballpoint, in case they took his papers. They did not take his papers. He did not have any. He hung drywall for thirty-one years, and by the end he could tape a seam so the light went across it like water across a plate, and contractors in three counties asked for him by name, which was Don Chepe.

Marta came two years later with the four oldest. They lived in two bedrooms in the garden apartments on Fourteenth Avenue, then in a basement off Riggs Road with a dehumidifier running day and night, then, in 1996, in a brick rambler with a carport at the dead end of a short street on the Hyattsville side, which they bought with drywall money and the money Marta made cleaning houses in Bethesda, and with a loan Don Chepe paid off eleven months early because he did not like owing. By then there were fourteen children. Seven sons and seven daughters, the oldest born in a mud-brick house in Cuscatlán with a lamp burning, the youngest at a hospital in Takoma Park with a television on the wall. People said it the way you say a bus route. *Los catorce de Don Chepe.*

Don Chepe gave things away. That was the other thing people said. On Saturdays he set up a griddle under the carport and made pupusas for whoever came: the men from the day-labor corner at the 7-Eleven, the Guatemalan family next door, Mr. Pratt across the street, who was retired from the Post Office and liked the bean and cheese with extra curtido, and anybody's cousin just off the bus from Houston with nowhere to sleep. Marta hemmed pants for free at the kitchen table and cooked for every funeral in the church whether she had known the dead person or not.

The children grew up and took after them, each one in a different direction, the way water takes after a hill. Rigoberto, the oldest, drove a thermos of coffee to the 7-Eleven corner at half past five every morning before his own shift. Ana Gloria did taxes for free every February at the same kitchen table where her mother hemmed. Wilfredo fixed cars in the carport on Sunday afternoons, and you paid for the parts. Iris interpreted at the clinic and the courthouse in Upper Marlboro. Nelson kept a Folgers can on the church's back table for sending bodies home, because a coffin to San Salvador could cost what a car cost, and when the can got too heavy he opened a bank account for it. Morena, the youngest daughter, taught English on Thursday nights in the room behind the sanctuary. Kevin, the baby, born in Takoma Park, ran a Facebook page where people posted what they needed and other people said *I have one*. There were others: a daughter who cut hair, a son who drove people to Dulles at four in the morning, a daughter who sent the money every year for the roof of the school in the canton, a son who did the TPS forms for half the street every eighteen months. Mr. Pratt counted it up once on the back of an envelope and said it came to sixteen, with the parents. Sixteen ways of giving something away, going out of one house every week, like the spokes of a wheel.

In 1997 Don Chepe planted an izote by the front walk. It was not an izote. The real izote, the national flower, the tree with the white blossoms that grows in every yard back home, will not live through a Maryland winter. The man at the nursery in Beltsville told him so, and sold him a yucca that grew wild from Maryland south, called Adam's needle, with

stiff leaves that curled threads off their edges. Don Chepe called it the izote anyway. Every June it sent up a stalk taller than he was, hung with cream-colored bells that turned toward the ground, and Marta picked the petals and fried them in egg the way they did at home, and they tasted almost right.

After the earthquakes in 2001 the government gave the Salvadorans who were here a paper called Temporary Protected Status, and Don Chepe went to the office and was fingerprinted and got a card with his picture on it, and for the first time in eighteen years he drove a car with a license in his wallet. He renewed it every eighteen months for sixteen years. He kept every card in a rubber band in his sock drawer, the expired ones too, and sometimes took them out and looked at them, his own face getting older on each one.

II. The Bed

Hyattsville · January to June, 2018

On the eighth of January it was on Univision. The government was ending the program for El Salvador. About two hundred thousand people, the man on the television said, had eighteen months to arrange their affairs. The last day was the ninth of September, 2019.

Ana Gloria turned the television off. Nobody in the kitchen said anything. Ten of the fourteen had been born in Maryland and were citizens. The four oldest had come up with their mother as children, and two of them were on the same cards as their father, and two were somewhere in between, in a file in an office that none of them had ever seen.

Don Chepe finished his coffee. *Eighteen months is a long time,* he said. *You can make a lot of pupusas in eighteen months.*

In February his eyes went yellow. In March a doctor at the hospital showed him a picture of the inside of him on a screen, with a shadow on the pancreas the shape of a thumbprint, and said months, and when Iris pressed her, said not many. Don Chepe laughed out loud in the examining room, and the doctor looked at Iris, and Iris had to explain.

He says good. He says he will leave before they make him.

He kept the griddle going under the carport through April, sitting on a kitchen chair, with Wilfredo flipping. In May the hospice brought a bed with rails and set it in the living room facing the front window, so that he could see the street and the izote and the cars coming down the dead end, and Marta slept on the couch beside it in her clothes.

Hermana Chayo came every Tuesday at five, on her way to work.

She was a short, square woman of seventy-four with her hair pulled back so tight it lifted her eyebrows, and she cleaned offices on K Street in Washington from six in the evening until two in the morning, and had for twenty-nine years. She came from Chalatenango. She had been on the Sumpul River in May of 1980, and she did not talk about it, and nobody asked. At the little church in the strip mall on University Boulevard, up a flight of stairs over a money-transfer place, between a dentist and a tax preparer, she was not the pastor. She had never been anything you could put on a sign. She led the Tuesday prayer circle and she was the one the church sent to the sick, and when somebody's son was in jail or somebody's husband was in a hospital that would not say where, people found that they were calling her before they called the pastor, and that she already knew.

She sat by the bed for twenty minutes every Tuesday in her blue work smock and said very little. Once she held his hand while he slept. Once she asked him about the roof of the school in the canton, whether it had held through the rains, and he talked for the whole twenty minutes and she listened as if roofs were the only thing in the world. Then she looked at her watch and stood and put her hand flat on top of his head, the way you would test a loaf, and went to catch the bus.

In the second week of June the izote put up its stalk. Don Chepe watched it from the bed. It came up a little every day, a green spear with the buds packed tight along it like teeth on a corncob, and on the Wednesday it opened, all at once, a hundred cream bells hanging over the front walk in the evening.

That night he called Rigoberto to the bed.

Call the hermana, he said. *Tell her to send me eight of the hermanos. Or sixteen. Tomorrow. Tell her I want to hear the Word.*

III. The Reading

The living room · Thursday evening

Hermana Chayo did not come herself. It was Thursday, and Thursday nights she had the whole twelfth floor of a law firm by herself because the other woman was out with her back. But she sent them. Eight came, as he had asked, and then four more, because word goes around, and they stood in the living room with their Bibles, and the ones who did not fit stood in the kitchen doorway. Don Rafa came, who had been a deacon in the church since it was in a basement, and drove the van, and drove Hermana Chayo home from K Street at two in the morning three nights a week because the buses stopped. Two sisters from the Tuesday circle came, and a young man named Ulises who had been out of the detention center in Virginia for six weeks, and a woman with a baby asleep on her shoulder. The fourteen were there too, most of them, and some of the grandchildren, and Marta, and Mr. Pratt standing just inside the front door with his hat in his hands.

Don Chepe opened his eyes and looked at them all for a long time.

Hermanos, he said. *It is going to be hard for me to see you after this. I am very tired. Read me just one thing.*

What do you want to hear, Don Chepe?

Juan catorce, he said. *The one about the way. The one everybody knows.*

Don Rafa opened his Bible to the place. It was the old Reina-Valera, the one with the accents on the little words that they don't put anymore, the one his mother had read to him by a kerosene lamp. He had a good reading voice, slow, and he read it the way you would read a letter out loud to someone who cannot see well, so that every word got there.

> *No se turbe vuestro corazón: creéis en Dios, creed también en mí. En la casa de mi Padre muchas moradas hay…*
>
> *Let not your heart be troubled: ye believe in God, believe also in me. In my Father's house are many mansions…*
>
> *— Juan 14:1–2 (Reina-Valera 1909); John 14:1–2 (KJV)*

At that moment six buses came down the dead end.

They came one behind the other with their lights on, slowly, the way buses come into a terminal, and pulled up along the curb in front of the house, though the street was not long enough to hold even one of them, and they fit. They were school buses from up north, the old long-nosed kind that people in El Salvador buy at auction and drive down through Mexico, and they had been painted the way they paint them at home, every inch. One was red with yellow flames along its flanks. One was purple and silver with a picture of a waterfall on the back. One was green and gold with chrome horns along the roof like a row of trumpets. They had strings of colored lights along their roofs and names across the visors over the windshields, the way the buses at home do: *Dios Es Amor*, *El Peregrino*, *Mi Reina*, a girl's name, a saint's name, a name in letters he could not read. Music came out of all of them at once, ranchera and cumbia and an old hymn, and it did not clash. Their engines idled. He could smell the diesel.

In the door of each bus a young man hung by one arm, the way the ayudantes hang at home, half in and half out, calling the route.

Don Chepe! Súbase, súbase! There's room, Don Chepe. Come with us.

And another: *Leave that old cántaro, Don Chepe. When the clay jar cracks you don't keep drinking out of it. You throw it out and get a gold one. Súbase!*

The doors were folded open. Inside, the seats were empty and clean.

Don Chepe lifted his hand off the blanket. He did not want to miss the next verse. Don Rafa was coming to the part about the way, the part he had asked for, and the young men in the doors were calling over it.

¡Esperen! he said. *¡Esperen!* Wait. Wait.

Don Rafa stopped reading with his finger on the line.

Nobody in the room moved. Then Ana Gloria began to cry, and then Iris, and then one of the sons who had come in from Houston, a big man who drove a truck, put his face in his hands. Ana Gloria said it out loud, to nobody, in the voice you use when you cannot help it.

He never could get enough of the Word. All his life. And now he asks for it and he stops it himself. She pressed her knuckles against her mouth. *In the end everybody is afraid. Everybody.*

The hermanos looked at one another over the bed. Don Rafa closed his Bible, carefully, with his finger still in it, then took his finger out.

This is not the time for us, he said quietly, and the others nodded.

They went out one at a time, touching Marta on the shoulder as they passed. They went down the front walk under the izote, with its hundred bells hanging in the dusk, and got into Don Rafa's van and the two cars and backed out carefully around the end of the street, where there was nothing parked but Mr. Pratt's Buick, and drove away.

IV. The Izote

The front walk · the same evening

After a while Don Chepe came back to himself and looked around the room.

Why are you crying?

Nobody wanted to say it. Finally Morena did, because she was the youngest daughter, and the youngest daughter in that family had always been allowed.

Papi, you sent for the hermanos, and they came, and they were reading what you asked for, and you told them to stop. You stopped them yourself. So we thought, even Papi. Even him, at the end.

Where are the hermanos?

They left. Don Rafa said it wasn't the time for them.

Don Chepe closed his eyes. *Ay, Rafa,* he said. *Mija, I wasn't talking to the hermanos.*

Then who were you talking to?

He told them. The six buses along the curb with their lights on. The paint. The music. The young men hanging in the doors calling him by his name, telling him to get on, telling him to leave the cracked jar and take the gold one. *They were talking over the Word,* he said. *I wanted to hear the end. I told them to wait.*

Wilfredo went to the window and looked out. The street was empty. A light was on in the Guatemalan family's kitchen next door. Mr. Pratt had

gone back across and was standing in his own driveway with the hose, watering his tomatoes in the last of the light.

Papi, there's nothing there. Just Mr. Pratt.

Don Chepe nodded as if that was what he had expected. *Is the izote open?*

Yes, Papi. Since yesterday.

Good. He lay quiet a while, gathering his breath. *The buses have names on them,* he said. *Like at home. Tell me. Which is the best place to go?*

They did not know what to say. Then Rigoberto, who was forty-seven and had a grandson of his own, and who remembered the house in Cuscatlán with the lamp burning, and his grandmother in it, said it.

The best place is where your mother and father are, Papi. Where Abuela Toya is.

Don Chepe opened his eyes and smiled at him. *One of them has her name,* he said. *On the glass. Like the girls' names on the buses. Niña Toya. The blue one.* He moved his hand toward the window. *Cut a stalk of the izote and throw it in the street. Say: this is for the bus from where my mother is.*

Wilfredo got the machete from the carport, the one his father had brought from home and never once used for anything in thirty-five years except hanging on a nail. He cut the stalk low, at the base, with one stroke, and lifted it. It was taller than he was and heavy with flowers, and the bells shook and a few fell on the walk. He gave it to Morena, because it was Morena's turn, and Morena carried it down to the curb with both arms, the way you carry a child that has fallen asleep, and stood there. Her brothers and sisters came out onto the front walk behind her. The Guatemalan family came out onto their step. Mr. Pratt turned off the hose.

For the bus from where Abuela is, Morena said, and threw it.

It went up. It did not come down. At the height of a bus's side mirror, about where a man's head would be if he were standing in the door, the stalk stopped in the air, as if it had caught on something, and hung there. It turned a little on itself. The bells swung. A few petals came loose and drifted down onto the asphalt, and the stalk went on hanging, in the June

evening, over the empty street, with nothing under it and nothing holding it.

Everybody on the dead end saw it. The fourteen saw it, and Marta in the doorway, and the Guatemalan family on their step, the grandmother crossing herself the Catholic way, and Mr. Pratt with the hose dripping on his shoes. Yesenia, the Guatemalan family's fifteen-year-old, had her phone up already, the way fifteen-year-olds do, and she filmed it. Everybody saw the flowers. Nobody saw any bus.

From the bed, through the window, Don Chepe could see it all.

Do you see the flowers? he called. His voice was clear.

We see them, Papi.

They are hanging on the bus from where my mother is. That's the one I'm taking. Don't be troubled. If you want to come where I'm going, keep doing what we did. All sixteen. Don't drop any.

Marta went to him. The children came in from the walk. He looked at all of them, and at the window, and he died with his eyes open and his hand lifted a little off the blanket, the way a man lifts his hand to steady himself on a rail when he is getting on.

And the stalk of flowers moved. It went slowly at first, as if something under it had let off its brake. It went down the dead end at the height of a bus window, turning the way a wide vehicle turns, carefully, around Mr. Pratt's Buick, and stopped at the corner as if for traffic, and turned right onto Riggs Road toward University Boulevard, and was gone. Mr. Pratt said afterward that he heard air brakes let go. Yesenia's video stops there, because she started crying and dropped her hand, and the last four seconds are the sidewalk and her own sneakers.

V. The Circle

New Hampshire Avenue · two in the morning

Don Rafa picked Hermana Chayo up at two, as he always did on Thursdays, at the side door of the building on K Street where the cleaners came out. She got in the van in her smock with her purse on her knees, and he drove up Sixteenth Street and across and out New Hamp-

SHIRE AVENUE TOWARD MARYLAND, PAST THE DARK EMBASSIES and then the dark churches and then the dark car lots, and for a long way he did not say anything.

Did he hear the Word? she asked at last.

Yes, hermana. We read him John fourteen, like he asked. But in the middle of it he called out, wait, wait, and stopped us. Then the children started crying. So we said, this isn't the time for us, and we left.

Hermana Chayo looked out the window at the orange barrels where they were tearing up the road for the new train.

He wasn't talking to you, Rafa.

Don Rafa kept his hands on the wheel. *Who was he talking to?*

To the ones who came for him. They came for him in the middle of the reading, and they were calling him to get on, and he didn't want to miss the end. So he told them to wait.

He drove a whole block before he said it. *Is that true, hermana?*

It's true.

Don Rafa had known her twenty-six years. He had driven her home from K Street maybe two thousand times. He did not ask her how she knew it, when she had been on the twelfth floor of a law firm all night with a vacuum on her back. He had stopped asking her things like that a long time ago.

Where did he go?

Where his mother is.

They came to the light at University Boulevard, and it was red, and there was nobody else at the intersection in any direction, and he stopped anyway.

Last Saturday he was under the carport with the griddle, Don Rafa said. *Sitting on a chair. Laughing at Wilfredo for burning them. Happy, with all of them around him. And now.*

And now he's gone where he's going to be happy, Hermana Chayo said. *It's the same, Rafa. The ones who live like that, they're glad here and they're glad there. They don't have to change anything to go.* She turned her purse over on her knees and opened it and took out her own Bible, small, with a rubber

band around it, and did not open it, only held it. *The apostle wrote it from prison,* she said. *He knew they might kill him. Listen to what he told them.*

> *Gozaos en el Señor siempre: otra vez digo: Que os gocéis.*
>
> *Rejoice in the Lord alway: and again I say, Rejoice.*
>
> *— Filipenses 4:4 (Reina-Valera 1909); Philippians 4:4 (KJV)*

The light went green. Don Rafa did not go. She said the other one then, the one they read at funerals, the one he had heard a hundred times in the church over the money-transfer place and in the funeral homes on Route 1, and had never really heard.

> *Y oí una voz del cielo que me decía: Escribe: Bienaventurados los muertos que de aquí adelante mueren en el Señor. Sí, dice el Espíritu, que descansarán de sus trabajos; porque sus obras con ellos siguen.*
>
> *And I heard a voice from heaven saying unto me, Write, Blessed are the dead which die in the Lord from henceforth: Yea, saith the Spirit, that they may rest from their labours; and their works do follow them.*
>
> *— Apocalipsis 14:13 (Reina-Valera 1909); Revelation 14:13 (KJV)*

Their works go with them, she said. *He's riding with all of it, Rafa. The coffee at the corner. The taxes. The cars. The coffee can for the bodies. He's sitting there looking at it out the window, all sixteen. He can see every one.*

The light went red again. A Metrobus went by on University with nobody in it, lit up like a fish tank. Don Rafa sat with both hands on the wheel and wept, which he had not done when his own father died in Usulután and he could not go home for the burial, and Hermana Chayo let him, and looked out the window, and did not touch him. When the light went green the third time he drove her home.

VI. The Way Home

Dulles, San Salvador, Suchitoto, Riggs Road · summer 2018

Nelson emptied the Folgers can. For once it was for his own father, and nobody said a word against it, and it was not enough, so the people it had been for came, the ones whose sons and husbands and mothers had gone home in it over twenty years, with envelopes. A man came all the way from Manassas with four hundred dollars in twenties and would not come in the house. The coffin went out of Dulles on a Tuesday in the belly of the plane, taking up the room of twelve suitcases, and Rigoberto and Marta flew with it, upstairs, with the tickets Kevin found on the internet.

Yesenia posted the video that night. By August it had been seen more than two million times. People in the comments said it was fishing line. People said it was a drone. People said it was the CGI. A man in Texas made a video of his own explaining how it was done, frame by frame, with arrows, and that one got two million too. Yesenia stopped reading the comments. Mr. Pratt, who did not have a Facebook, told anybody who asked that he had been standing right there with the hose, and that the only thing in the air on that street was flowers, and that he was seventy-one years old and had carried the mail for thirty-four of them and did not need anybody in Texas to tell him what he saw on his own street.

In the canton outside Suchitoto they say a thing too. They say that on the Thursday night in June, before anyone there knew he was dead, an old woman who had known Niña Toya was sitting outside her door on the road up from the lake, and she saw flowers go by. A stalk of white flowers, she said, going up the hill in the dark, at the height of a bus window, with no bus. She said she heard music. She said it went up past the school, under the new roof, and on up the hill past where the Alvarengas' house had been, toward the cemetery, and stopped there. The coffin got there eight days later, and they buried him next to his mother, and on the cemetery wall by her grave, people say, there was a stalk of izote flowers lying on top of the wall, a little brown at the edges, the wrong kind, the kind that only grows up north.

In October a judge in San Francisco stopped the deadline, for the time being. Ana Gloria did the forms anyway, for everyone on the street, the way her father would have, and kept a copy of each one in a rubber band.

• • •

The fourteen kept the sixteen. They had promised him in the living room, all of them, without saying so. Rigoberto kept driving the coffee. Iris kept interpreting. Nelson bought a new Folgers can, because the old one had gone in the coffin, under the pillow, where Marta put it. The sixteenth, the one that had been Don Chepe's, Marta took. On the first Saturday in July she set up the griddle under the carport, by herself, at seven in the morning, and stood there, and after a while the men from the corner began to come down the dead end in ones and twos, as if they had been waiting for somebody to say so.

Mr. Pratt came across with a paper plate. Bean and cheese, extra curtido. He stood by the izote while he ate. Its leaves were curling their white threads in the heat, the way they do, and at the base, low down, where Wilfredo had cut the stalk, there was a clean pale stump the width of a man's wrist, and beside it, already as tall as Mr. Pratt's knee, out of season, a new green spear was coming up.

Background

The verse

> *The virtuous man delights in this world, and he delights in the next; he delights in both. He delights and rejoices, when he sees the purity of his own work.*
>
> Dhammapada 16, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Dhammika is a lay disciple of Sāvatthī who, with his wife and fourteen children, keeps up sixteen different kinds of almsgiving. Dying, he asks the Buddha to send monks to recite the discourse on mindfulness. In the middle of it, six chariots arrive from six heavens to carry him away, and he cries "Wait! Wait!" to them. The monks think he means them, stop, and leave, and his children weep that even their father fears death. He explains, has them throw a garland of flowers, and the garland hangs in the air on the pole of the invisible chariot from the Tusita heav-

en, "the abode of the mothers and fathers of the Buddhas." He dies and is reborn there, and the Buddha tells the monks that the righteous rejoice in both worlds. Read the full commentary story, or about the Tusita heaven.

Hyattsville, Maryland

Prince George's County, 2018

Salvadorans began arriving in the Washington suburbs in large numbers during the civil war of 1979–1992, which killed some 75,000 people; among its worst atrocities was the Sumpul River massacre in Chalatenango in May 1980. By 2000, Langley Park, built after World War II as garden apartments around the intersection of University Boulevard and New Hampshire Avenue, had the highest proportion of Salvadoran residents of any place in the United States. Salvadoran Americans are now one of the largest Latino groups in the country. Many belong to hometown associations that raise money for roads, water systems and schools in the towns they came from, and families sending a body home have long relied on collections among coworkers and neighbors, since repatriation can cost many thousands of dollars.

After two earthquakes struck El Salvador in early 2001, the U.S. granted Salvadorans already in the country Temporary Protected Status, renewable every eighteen months. On January 8, 2018, the Department of Homeland Security announced it would end TPS for El Salvador, giving about 200,000 people until September 9, 2019 to leave or find another status. On October 3, 2018, a federal court in California blocked the terminations in *Ramos v. Nielsen*, and the litigation kept the program alive for years. The buses in Don Chepe's vision are the brightly painted former school buses of Central America, often called chicken buses. The izote (*Yucca gigantea*), whose flowers are eaten, is El Salvador's national flower; it cannot survive a Maryland winter, but its cousin Adam's needle grows wild there.

After the story of the lay disciple Dhammika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 16). The original. Scripture from the Reina-Valera Bible (1909) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.12

Horseshoe Lake

> *So We caused the earth to swallow him and his dwelling-place.*
> *— Qur'an 28:81*

Ovako sam čuo, on Holly Hills Boulevard.

I. The Washers

Gravois Avenue, St. Louis · 2004 and after

Ramiz-efendija Kurtović came to St. Louis in 1998 from the Pešter plateau in Sandžak, where the winter is so long that the sheep come down off the summer grass in September. For six years he mopped floors at night in a hospital on Kingshighway and on Fridays led the prayer in a rented room over a car-parts store. In 2004 the džemat bought the old furniture store on Gravois and could pay him, a little. The first thing he asked for was young men to learn the washing of the dead.

He asked it from the minbar, in the plain way he said everything. At home the old men had done it. Here the old men were tired, or in the ground, or had never learned. *Who is going to wash us,* he said, *when it is our turn?*

Six came, all from the same few streets, all between twenty and twenty-five. The Mujkić brothers, Kenan and Mirza, whose father had the biggest house on Itaska Street and the first Mercedes on Gravois. Samir Karić, who was studying to be a pharmacist. Emir Selimović, just down from Utica, who drove a truck for Fadil Kovač. Nermin Hadžić, who had the best voice of any young man in the džemat and had been told so since he was nine. And Haris Mehmedović, who was from Goražde.

About Haris the street had a story. In the siege, when the food came down at night by parachute and there was never enough of it, his mother had never once said to him *nema*, there isn't any. Whatever there was she put in front of him and went without. One evening in the winter of 1994 there was nothing in the house at all, and he called up from the street that he was hungry, and she thought, well, now he will learn the word. She set an empty baking tray on the table and turned another tray over it for a lid and sent it down to him by his sister. He lifted the lid in the snow, and it was full of pita, hot, potato and cheese, enough for him and every boy on the street. He came up and asked her why she had never made that kind before. After that whenever he was hungry she sent down the covered tray, and it came full, until the war was over. Haris always said he did not remember any of it. His sister did.

The six went to the imam together, and they took Bego with them.

Bego Sejdić was a Rom from Tuzla. He had cut all their hair since they were boys in a chair at the back of the car-parts store, and swept up after the Friday prayer for six years without anybody asking him to. At the door of the washing room the six took off their watches and their gold chains and handed them to Bego to hold, the way you would to a boy, and told him to go on home, they would get them later. He went as far as the corner. Then he thought, if one chain goes missing they will say the Gypsy took it, and he thought, these six are going in there to learn to wash the dead, and I am going home to hold their gold? He hung everything on the hook inside the door of the hall where anyone could see it and came back.

It was Kenan Mujkić who said it, the elder brother. *Efendija, we are proud. You know us. Bego has cut our hair for ten years. Teach him first. Then we will have to stand behind him.*

So the imam taught Bego first, the water and the cloths and the order of it, right side before left, and the six stood behind a Gypsy barber and learned it over his shoulder, and something in each of them that had been standing up sat down.

They all learned it, in time. The Mujkić brothers went into their father's business and Kenan was president of the džemat by 2010. Samir got

his license and filled the street's prescriptions for half price. Haris went to the optometry school at the university and fit half of Bevo with glasses, and was said to see things before other people did. Emir came when he was not on the road. Bego washed more of the dead than all the rest together. And Nermin learned the words fastest, the prayers for the washing and for the grave, and the forms at the county, and which window, and had his voice. That was what he learned. The imam never said what he thought of it.

II. The Lickspittle

Bevo Mill and Oakville · autumn 2017 *to spring* 2018

After the summer of the cloak, people on Gravois stood a little differently around Nermin Hadžić. Nothing was said. But when a family came into the hall now to ask for someone to wash their father, they asked for the imam, or for Bego, or for Emir if he was in town. They asked whether the hafiz was coming back for Ramadan. They asked after Haris, and after Kenan, and after the hafiz's young muezzin, whose name they had already forgotten. Nobody asked where Nermin was. He stood at the back of the hall in the tea-colored jacket with the fox collar and listened to them not ask.

He thought about it in the evenings. I went in with them, he thought. I learned it faster than any of them. What do they have that I don't? He thought about who he could go to. Not the Mujkić family; Kenan was president and had a long memory. Not Fadil Kovač, who had given the money for the building and the cloak both, and who had prayed every prayer in the hall since 2004 in the same place, behind the imam on the right. But Fadil had a son.

Dino Kovač was thirty-one. He had an MBA from Saint Louis University and an office at the company's yard in Oakville with a window onto forty trucks, and he knew what every man on Gravois was paid and nothing at all about what any of them was worth. His father would not retire. His father still drove a truck himself four times a year to remember how.

Nermin went to the yard one night in October without calling first. Dino was alone at his computer and turned around and found a man standing behind him in the dark office, close, in a hooded sweatshirt, and jumped so hard he knocked his coffee onto the keyboard.

Who is that?

It's Nermin. He pushed the hood back and laughed and helped him mop it up, and the next time he came he came in daylight, in his black robe, and was let in.

That winter he was at the yard more than he was at the hall. Dino gave him a title, chaplain to the drivers, and a salary, and a black Tahoe with the company name on the doors, and paid for him to go live on Facebook every Thursday night reciting, so that drivers in Texas and Ohio and Pennsylvania could listen in their cabs. Families who had stopped calling him began to call him again, because he was in Dino's office. He was invited to dinners. And on the night it first came to him whole, standing in the Kovač kitchen with a plate of baklava, that he should be the one leading the džemat and not an old janitor from Sandžak, his voice went. It did not go all at once. It cracked on the high note of the call to prayer the next morning, and after that it cracked whenever he reached for it, and a throat doctor in south county looked down his throat with a light and said nodules, rest it. He did not rest it.

Fadil Kovač had a small stroke in January, at the wheel of his own car in the yard, and was in the hospital a week.

People used to live long, Nermin said to Dino, in the office, with the door shut. *Now they don't. You know how long his father lived? Ninety-one. He'll come back from this and go another fifteen years and you'll be fifty before you sign a check. Do it now, while you're young enough to enjoy it. You take the company. I'll take the džemat.*

Dino had a lawyer by February and a power of attorney by March. He moved his father to a nursing home in south county, a clean one, with a fountain in the lobby, and told the front desk that only family could visit and that his mother was not to bring food from home, because of the old man's heart. Hajra Kovač brought it anyway, a little pita at a time in her handbag, under her scarf. Then the desk began looking in her handbag.

Fadil stopped eating what the home gave him. He said it had no taste. He died at the end of April, and Ramiz-efendija, who had not been allowed in to see him once, washed him with Bego, and buried him, and said nothing to Dino at the grave but what is said to every son.

At the džemat's yearly assembly in March Nermin had stood up, before the budget, in the black robe, with Dino in the first row. Dino had pledged sixty thousand dollars for the new roof.

Efendija, Nermin said, and put his hand on his heart, and made his cracked voice soft. *You are seventy-five years old. You have carried this džemat on your back for twenty years. You are tired. We can all see it. Rest. Sit with your grandchildren. Let me carry it for you.*

The hall was quiet. Ramiz-efendija looked at him a while from the table at the front.

I would not give it to the hafiz, he said. *I would not give it to Bego. And I should give it to an ulizica?*

It is a word for a man who licks up after someone, a lickspittle. Nobody in the hall had ever heard the imam call any man a name. He said it the way he said everything, not loudly, and went on to the roof.

The board met the next week and voted that Nermin Hadžić was not to lead the prayer in that hall again, or recite in it, until further notice. Kenan Mujkić read it out on Friday. Nermin sat in the last row and heard his name read, and from that day he hated the old man, which he had not done before.

III. The Truck

Holly Hills and Gravois · summer 2018

Ramiz-efendija lived on Holly Hills Boulevard, in a brick house across from Carondelet Park, with his daughter and her husband and three grandchildren. In May two of Dino's drivers came to see him there at nine o'clock at night. They were Šemso Hodžić and a young one called Kemal, and they had been paid five hundred dollars each by somebody to go and talk to the old man, as it had been put to them, and

MAKE HIM UNDERSTAND THAT HE WAS TIRED. ŠEMSO HAD brought a tire iron and left it in the truck.

The imam opened the door himself in his slippers. He looked at the two of them a moment and said, *Come in, the coffee is on,* though it was not, and went and put it on. They sat in the front room for three hours. His granddaughter brought them Turkish delight on a plate. Mostly the old man asked Šemso about his mother, who was from a village near Sjenica where the imam had known a cousin, and Šemso, who had not cried since 1995, cried in the imam's front room, and Kemal looked at the carpet. On Friday both of them were in the hall, at the back, and came every Friday after, and gave the money to the džemat, and told Dino so.

In June, on the last Friday of Ramadan, the imam was at the side door of the hall taking off his shoes when a brick came off the parapet two stories up and broke on the concrete step beside him. A piece of it went into his foot through the sock. Nermin had keys to the roof, because he had always seen to the air conditioner, and he was up there, and said afterward he had been seeing to it. Zijad the roofer went up that afternoon and came down and said only that the bricks on that parapet were mortared and he had laid them himself. The imam had Bego pick the brick out of his foot with tweezers and wash it and tape it, and led the prayer in his socks with a little blood coming through, and that was all he said about it.

Dino had paid for the kurban that year. At Kurban Bajram in August, the meat of eleven lambs was to be given out in the lot behind the hall after the prayer, and he had brought a new tractor to the alley beside the lot to be looked at, a black Mack with chrome stacks and KOVAČ in silver on the doors, the newest truck in the fleet. The alley runs downhill into the lot. The prayer was in the lot, under the August sun, eight hundred men in rows on tarps and prayer rugs and flattened cardboard, the women under the tents at the side.

Somebody had pulled the chocks. Somebody had climbed into the cab while the rows were bowing and pushed in the yellow knob on the dash, and the truck came down the alley slowly, the way a big animal walks

when it means it, and into the lot, and toward the front of the rows, where the imam was standing alone facing the wall with his hands raised.

Emir Selimović was in the second row. He had driven all night from Memphis to be there. He did not decide anything. He was up and out of the row and standing between the truck and the old man with his arms out before the people behind him had finished screaming, and he had time to see the chrome of the grille coming, and the bulldog on the hood, and his own face in the bumper.

The imam had turned around. He put up one hand, the palm out, the way you would to a horse.

The truck stopped. Eight hundred people saw it. It stopped a hand's width from Emir's chest, with a long sigh of air, and then the front of it went down, slowly, until the bumper was nearly on the asphalt, the way a camel goes down, or an elephant in a picture book, onto its knees. The imam lowered his hand. He turned back to the wall and began the prayer again from the beginning, and after a while, one by one, the rows behind him did too.

Afterward people talked about the air brakes, and about the springs, and about the yard man Dino had brought with him, who was fired that same afternoon and by Christmas was driving for a company in Chicago. It did not matter what they said. The brick could be a loose brick and the drivers could be two men who had stopped by for coffee and Fadil could have been an old man with a weak heart. But eight hundred people had seen a truck come down that alley at the imam, and they knew whose truck it was, and who had been riding around for a year in Dino Kovač's Tahoe with Dino Kovač's name on the doors. Hajra Kovač said in the lot, in front of everyone, what Dino had done to his father. Nobody took the Kovač meat home. It went to the shelter on Chippewa.

Dino took the Tahoe back the following week, and the title, and the salary, and stopped paying for Thursday nights on Facebook. The families stopped calling Nermin to wash their dead. When he went to the houses where he had always been welcome at iftar, nobody came to the door, though the lights were on and he could hear the television.

IV. The Clipboard

Gravois and Affton · October 2018 to June 2019

In October he asked to speak at an extraordinary meeting of the džemat, and the board, because it was the rule, let him. He had five things to put before them. Every man in the džemat should pray all five prayers in the hall and none at home. Every man should fast Mondays and Thursdays, all year. No meat should be eaten in any house but at the two Bajrams. No man or woman should wear gold. No wedding should have music. He said them in his broken voice, standing, with a sheet of paper.

The imam heard him out. *The Prophet fasted Mondays and Thursdays,* he said. *Whoever wants to, let him fast. Whoever wants to eat no meat, let him eat bread. Whoever can come to all five prayers, I'll be glad to see him. I will not make a law where God made none.*

Nermin turned to the hall. *Brothers. Whose words are stricter, his or mine? Whoever wants to be saved, come with me.* And he took a clipboard from under his arm, with a sign-up sheet on it, and walked out to the parking lot and stood there under the light with a pen on a string.

Forty-three young men signed it. Most of them were under twenty-five, sons of drivers, boys who had been born in St. Louis and learned their prayers on Saturdays and had never had anybody ask anything hard of them in their lives. They went with him to a building in Affton that had been a Pizza Hut, out on Gravois Road past the city line, with the red roof still on it, and on Fridays they prayed there on carpet laid over the old floor, and Nermin preached.

The imam said nothing against it from the minbar. Once, in his Wednesday lesson, when somebody told him that Nermin had begun sitting at the front of the Pizza Hut with a young man on either side of him, the way the imam sat at Ramadan with the hafiz on one side and the muezzin on the other, and was holding his hands the way the imam held his, the old man told a story instead.

On the Lim, he said, *below my village, there was a cormorant who fished the deep pool under the bridge, and a crow who came to watch him. The cormorant*

fed him the little fish. One day the crow said, he's black and I'm black, he has a beak and I have a beak, what do I need him for? And he went into the pool after the fish himself, and the weeds took him, and that was the last of him. It's not the color that fishes, the imam said, and went on with the lesson, which was about the conditions of the fast.

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In May the hafiz Senad Mehić came back from Sarajevo for Ramadan with Adem the muezzin. On the fifteenth night, after the iftar, the two of them borrowed Emir's minivan and drove out Gravois to Affton. Senad wore the gray socks with the red band that his old teacher had knit him, and when he took off his shoes in the doorway of the Pizza Hut, the boys saw them.

Nermin was at the front, between his two young men. He looked up and saw the hafiz in the door, and it went through the room that the hafiz had come over to Nermin, and Nermin smiled and waved him in to sit beside him and said, *Senad, you're tired, recite for us, I'll rest my voice.* He lay down on a cushion by the wall and slept, as he did most nights now, early.

Senad did not sit up front. He sat down on the floor among the boys and recited. He recited the sura of the Cave, the whole of it, from memory, too fast, the way he always had, and when he finished, Adem went out into the parking lot under the Pizza Hut sign and gave the call to the night prayer in a voice that the people at the gas station across Gravois Road stopped pumping to listen to. Then the two of them got up and walked out to Emir's minivan. Thirty-nine of the forty-three boys went with them, some in the van and the rest in their own cars behind.

Mrs. Suljić, who lived on the corner of Gravois and Delor and did not sleep, said she saw them come back up Gravois a little after midnight, the van in front and the cars behind it in a line, and that the van's wheels were not on the street. Her son said she needed new glasses. She went to Haris for them, and he gave her the new glasses, and she said the same thing.

Hamza Ćosić, who had been Nermin's friend since the refugee center in 1997 and had never liked the hafiz, woke Nermin on the cushion. *Get*

up. Senad's taken your boys. Didn't I tell you? Didn't I say, don't trust the Sarajevo ones?

Nermin sat up. *Senad wants what I have,* he said. *He always did. On the same bench he wanted it.* And he struck himself in the chest with his fist, hard, twice, the way a man does who means it, and the blood came up out of his mouth onto the old Pizza Hut carpet.

At the hall that night, when the boys came in, the old men stood up from the tables. The hafiz had gone out with one young muezzin and come back with a crowd behind him. Ramiz-efendija told a story then too, standing at the tea urn.

On the Pešter, he said, *there was an old shepherd with two sons, and when he got too old to take the sheep up to the summer grass he gave each boy half the flock. Up there on the high pasture there are wolves, and below there are villages, and the people of the villages know when the flocks come down in September, and they wait by the road for a stray. One boy brought his sheep down by daylight, the short way, past every house, and every house had one of his sheep for supper, and he came home to his father with eleven. The other brought his down at night, the long way, around by the ridge, and never once went near a village, and came home with every sheep he took up and the lambs besides. You should have seen the old man's face,* the imam said, and laughed, and looked at Senad, who was standing at the sink with his sleeves rolled up, washing the big pots.

V. Horseshoe Lake

Affton and Carondelet Park · February 2020

IT WAS IN HIS STOMACH, AND BY THE TIME THE DOCTORS AT Barnes looked, it was in his liver too. He was sick for nine months. Dino did not come. Of the four boys who had stayed at the Pizza Hut, three went home by Christmas, and the lease ran out on the building in January, and Nermin lay in a rented room above a nail salon on Gravois Road with Hamza and the last boy, Edin, who was seventeen, to bring him water.

In February he asked to see the imam.

Take me to him.

Hamza said no. *When you were on your feet you threw bricks at him. You sent a truck at him. Now you want him?*

I hated him, Nermin said. *I'll give you that. But he never hated me. Not this much.* He held up his finger and thumb with nothing between them. *Not one hair. Take me.*

He said it every hour, and on the third day they did it. They laid him on the mattress in the back of Hamza's minivan with the seats folded down, and drove him in along Loughborough Avenue toward Holly Hills, and Edin called ahead to his cousin on Itaska Street, who called the imam's son-in-law, who told the imam.

Nermin is coming to see you, efendija. Hamza's bringing him.

The old man was in his chair by the front window. *He won't see me,* he said. He did not say it as a man says he will not let somebody in. He said it the way you would say it was going to rain.

The phones went on all afternoon. *They're on Gravois. They've turned off Gravois. They're on Loughborough. They're at the park.* His grandchildren were at the window. *Even if he gets to the door,* the imam said, *he won't see me.*

It was the time for the afternoon prayer, and Hamza would not take a man to the imam's house without the abdest, so he pulled into the lot by Horseshoe Lake, on the south side of the park, and he and Edin went down to the edge of the water to wash, though it was February and the water was black and cold. They left the side door open. Nermin got himself out of the van. He walked the few steps to a bench at the top of the bank, and sat down on it, and put both his feet on the ground.

Carondelet Park is old ground. Under it the rock is full of holes, and the lakes themselves were sinkholes once that the city joined up and filled with water a hundred years ago. It had rained all week and thawed. Edin had his hands in the water when he heard a sound behind him like a sheet of plywood being slowly laid down, and turned, and Nermin was in the ground to his ankles, sitting on the bench, which was going too.

He went down slowly. Edin said that afterward to everyone who asked, and to the police, and to the man from the city, and to the imam. To his

knees. To his waist. Edin ran up the bank and caught him under the arms and could not hold him, it was like holding a man in a river, and Hamza came and they both pulled and it took him to his chest, and then to his neck, and Hamza was on his knees in the mud and Edin was crying. Nermin's face was quiet. His jaw was on the grass. He looked up the long slope of the park toward Holly Hills, where the imam's house was, and with the ground holding his jaw he said the words he had said into a hundred dying ears, in the bad cracked voice and then, for the last of it, in the old one, the one he had when he was nine.

Ešhedu en la ilahe illallah, ve ešhedu enne Muhammeden abduhu ve resuluhu.

Then the grass closed over the place like a mouth.

The fire department came, and the city, and dug for two days with a backhoe in the rain while the hole kept filling, and found the bench, upside down, nine feet down, and nothing else. A man from the city said the clay down there was like pudding, and that the rock under the clay was like a sponge, and that you could lose a car in it. They put a fence around the place and in March they filled it with crushed rock, load after load, and tamped it, and put the dirt back over the top.

VI. Ah, Welladay

Gravois and Holly Hills · March 2020

Ramiz-efendija went to the fence the first night, after the night prayer, alone, with a flashlight. He stood at the chain-link with the lake behind him and recited the Yasin over the hole, the whole of it, the way it is recited over the dying, and when he came home he called Kenan Mujkić and told him to take the džemat book out of the safe and write Nermin Hadžić's name in it again, where it had been struck out in 2018, as a member in good standing.

Efendija. After everything?

He was on his way here, the imam said. *Write it.*

There was no washing, because there was nothing to wash. There was no grave.

On Gravois it was not the same as a death. People who had not said Nermin's name in a year said it over and over now, at the bakery and at the butcher's and on the phones between the trucks, and some of them said it was God's justice and said it with satisfaction, and a girl on Facebook posted the verse about Korah, whom the earth swallowed, and four hundred people shared it. On the Friday after, the women brought trays of baklava and tulumbe to the hall and set them out after the prayer, the way you would for a wedding or a boy coming home from the army, and the men stood around the tables eating and talking about the ground in the park.

Bego Sejdić did not eat. He stood by the door with his coat on, and he was crying.

Bego. What's the matter with you? You of all people. He slapped your neck every time he came into your shop, coming and going. Cigo, he called you, for twenty years.

Every time, Bego said. *Going in and coming out. I'm not crying because he's gone.* He wiped his face with his hand. *I'm crying because he'll be too much for them down there. He'll slap the angels. And they'll say, take him back, we can't stand him, send him up. And he'll come back in my door.*

Ramiz-efendija had been watching the tables from the minbar steps, with his shoes off, in his socks. He stood and asked for quiet, and recited, and then said it again in Bosnian for the young ones, the verses that come after Korah, which the girl had not posted.

> *So We caused the earth to swallow him and his dwelling-place. Then he had no host to help him against Allah, nor was he of those who can save themselves.*
>
> *And morning found those who had coveted his place but yesterday crying: Ah, welladay! Allah enlargeth the provision for whom He will of His slaves and straiteneth it (for whom He will). If Allah had not been gracious unto us He would have caused it to swallow us (also). Ah, welladay! the disbelievers never prosper.*
>
> *— Qur'an 28:81–82*

Us also, he said. *That's who is talking in that verse. The ones eating the baklava.* And he sat down, and after a while people began to put the baklava back on the trays.

• • •

Hamza Ćosić came to the hall for the first time in two years the next week, and sat in the back, and afterward he told the imam a dream. He had dreamed of Nermin standing in a room of black iron, up to his chin in an iron floor, with iron bars going through him from all four walls and one more down through the top of his head, so that he could not turn it to see who was coming in the door.

Edin was with him. He had not slept much since the park. He asked it straight out, the way the boys born in St. Louis ask things.

Efendija. Where is he now?

The old man looked at the boy for a long time. Then he gave him two verses, from two places in the Book, one after the other, the way you hand somebody two things to carry.

> *For them is torment in the life of the world, and verily the doom of the Hereafter is more painful, and they have no defender from Allah.*
>
> *— Qur'an 13:34*
>
> *And hell is brought near that day; on that day man will remember, but how will the remembrance (then avail him)? He will say: Ah, would that I had sent before me (some provision) for my life!*
>
> *— Qur'an 89:23–24*

Here, and there, and remembering, the imam said. *That's where he is.* He put his hand on Edin's head. *And he said the words. You heard him. God knows the rest, and the rest is long.*

In April the city seeded the fill. The grass came up thin over the crushed rock, a paler green than the grass around it, in a ragged round the size of a room, and the Canada geese that winter on Horseshoe Lake liked it better than any other place in the park. They stood on it in the mornings in a crowd, forty or fifty of them, pulling at the new grass, and

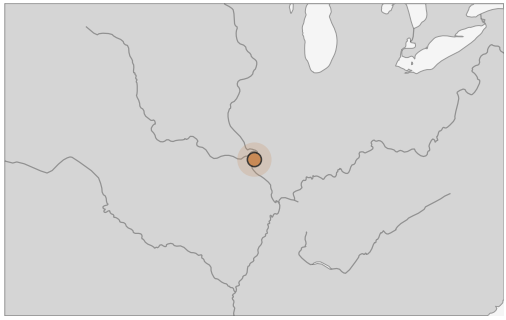
when anyone came down the path from Holly Hills they all lifted their heads at once and looked, and then went back to eating, and did not move off.

Background

The verse

> *The evil-doer suffers in this world, and he suffers in the next; he suffers in both. He suffers when he thinks of the evil he has done; he suffers more when going on the evil path.*
>
> Dhammapada 17, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary gives Devadatta's whole career. He goes forth with five Sakyan princes, among them Anuruddha (whose mother once sent him an empty covered bowl to teach him the words "there isn't any," and the gods filled it), and with their barber Upāli, whom the princes have ordained first to humble their pride. Devadatta gains only lesser powers. When visitors ask after every great disciple but him, he wins over Prince Ajātasattu, appearing to him first in a frightening form; loses his powers the moment he wants to lead the order; asks the aging Buddha to hand it over; is refused and called a lickspittle. He urges Ajātasattu to kill his father the king, hires assassins who are converted instead, hurls down a rock that wounds the Buddha's foot, and sends the drunken elephant Nālāgiri, before which Ānanda stands. After the elephant the people turn on him and the king withdraws his support. He demands five stricter rules, is told that whoever wishes may keep them, leads five hundred young monks away by a vote with tickets, and imitates the Buddha's manner until Sāriputta and Moggallāna bring the monks back. He coughs up hot blood, is sick nine months, and asks to be carried to the Buddha, who says he will not see him; set down by the lotus pool at Jetavana while his bearers bathe, he sinks into the earth, taking refuge in the Buddha with his last breath. The people celebrate, and a birth story tells of a doorkeeper who wept at a cruel king's funeral for fear he would be sent back. This story continues Four Votes (1.7). Read the full commentary story, or about Devadatta.



Bevo Mill and Carondelet Park, St. Louis, Missouri

South St. Louis, 2017–2020

Refugees from the Bosnian war settled in St. Louis by the tens of thousands from the 1990s on, first in Bevo Mill and then increasingly in the suburbs of south St. Louis County, and founded coffee shops, bakeries, auto shops and trucking companies (see History of Bosnian Americans in St. Louis). Some came from beyond Bosnia, from the Bosniak region of Sandžak in Serbia and Montenegro, which takes in the high Pešter plateau. Goražde, in eastern Bosnia, was besieged from 1992 to 1995; when the convoys were cut off, food was dropped to it from the air. The džemat, its people, the Kovač company, the old Pizza Hut and the collapse at the lake are invented.

Carondelet Park, some 180 acres on the city's south side, was bought by the city in 1874 and opened the next year. Its rolling ground was shaped by caves and sinkholes in the limestone beneath it: Horseshoe Lake was made in 1913 by joining nine sinkholes, and the boathouse went up in 1918. The Qur'an tells of Korah (Qarun), one of Moses' own people, who grew proud of his wealth and was swallowed by the earth with his house (28:76–82). The scripture is from Marmaduke Pickthall's translation, *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran* (1930).

After the story of Devadatta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 17). The original. Scripture from the Qur’an in Marmaduke Pickthall’s translation (1930). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

1.13

Little Brother

They are happy now, and we
Soon their happiness shall see.
— John Cennick, "Children of the Heavenly King" (1742)

So ist mir's erzählt worden, on the square at Salem.

I. The Guest Table

Salem, Wachovia, North Carolina · 1800 *to* 1815

Brother Heinrich Rothe kept the tavern at the lower end of Main Street, where the Brethren had put it on purpose, a good walk from the square, so that the wagoners and drovers and lawyers who stopped there would trouble the town as little as possible. He fed them all. In a week when the wagons were moving he fed sixty at a sitting. But that was the congregation's business, done for the congregation's account, and it was not what people meant when they spoke of Brother Rothe's table.

They meant the table in the back room. Any brother or sister on the road for the Saviour ate there, and the Elders had put it in his charge. Missionaries going out to the Cherokee at Springplace ate there, and ministers on the five-week road from Bethlehem, and the country preachers in from Friedberg and Hope with mud to the knee. Nobody at that table paid. In sixteen years it was hardly empty for a week together.

He had a gift for it, and the gift was known. In all of Wachovia nobody held a lovefeast without asking Brother Rothe first. He knew how many buns Bethania would eat and how many it would carry home in its pockets. He knew that Friedberg wanted the coffee sweet and Bethabara wanted it strong, and that the mugs must go down the benches oldest

first, and what a room full of people can hear while they are chewing. A congregation could spend twenty dollars on a lovefeast, and if it had not asked him the people went home saying, *What kind of a lovefeast was that?* So they asked, and he went. He rode to Bethania and Friedland and out to Hope, and he stood in other people's kitchens counting other people's buns. Sister Krause, the baker's widow, was sent for in the same way, and for the same reason. She had long since put her granddaughter at her own ovens.

And so it came about that the one table in Wachovia where Brother Rothe did not serve was his own.

His wife had gone home to the Saviour in 1799. He had three daughters. He put the eldest, Anna Rosina, in charge of the back room when she was sixteen, to lay the cloth and carry in the dishes and stand by the wall with the coffee pot while the guests talked. Sarah, the cook, sent the dishes out to her. Sarah belonged to the congregation, which had bought her in 1788 and hired her to the tavern, and she had been a communicant sister nearly as long as Anna Rosina had been alive. For some years now, by a rule of the Elders, she had sat for worship on the last bench.

The guests at that table talked of one thing. A girl who stood by that wall for three years heard more of the Saviour than most people hear in a lifetime of sermons, and heard it from tired people with their boots off, who had nothing to gain by it. In her second year Anna Rosina came to her father one evening with a white face and said that something had happened to her at the wall, that she had seen her own heart and it was settled, and she could not say more. He understood her. The same thing had happened to him, late, at forty, on a Good Friday, in the middle of the reading. It was the best thing he owned.

II. The Lot

Salem · 1806 *to* 1815

In Salem in those years nobody married without the Lot. A brother who wished to marry said so to the Elders, or the Elders thought of it for him, and a sister's name was proposed. Then they laid it

before the Saviour. There was a bowl with three slips of paper rolled in it, one that said Yes, one that said No, and one blank, which meant the question should not have been asked. An Elder drew. If the slip said Yes the sister was asked, and might still refuse. If it said No, that was the end of it, and nobody spoke of it again, or was supposed to.

In 1806 the name of Anna Rosina Rothe was proposed for a brother called to the Cherokee mission, and the Lot said Yes, and so did she. She went out to Springplace on a wagon in October with a feather bed and a box of slates. Her father put the second daughter, Maria Elisabeth, at the wall in the back room.

Maria Elisabeth stood there four years. The same thing happened to her that had happened to her sister, in her own time and her own way, over a dish of stewed apples, while a deaf old preacher from Hope was telling how he had been found. In 1810 the Lot said Yes for her and a miller at Bethania, and she went to live at the mill.

That left Benigna. She was fifteen and the smallest of the three, with a way of laughing through her nose that her father had tried to correct and then given up on. She took the coffee pot from her sister and stood at the wall.

A Virginia wagoner had once settled his reckoning at the tavern with a peacock, having nothing else, and the bird lived on in the stable yard for years and screamed at every team that came in. Benigna fed it from her apron. She gathered the tail feathers when it dropped them and stood them in a brown jug on the sill of the back room, where the guests could look at them, and the Elders, who did not care for finery, let it pass, since nobody had made them.

She stood there six years. Whatever had come to her sisters at that table came to her as well, and early, in her first winter. It did not stop there. The guests noticed it before her father did. Missionaries who had buried children in Surinam fell into the way of turning in their chairs and asking the girl with the coffee pot what she thought, and listening to the answer. An old bishop from Bethlehem, on his way through, said to Brother Rothe on the stairs, *That one has been further along the road than I have. Do you know it?* Brother Rothe took it as a courtesy to the house.

One autumn a missionary's wife came through from the Danish islands. She had buried her third child at St. Thomas and had not slept a night through since. She sat on at the table after the others had gone up. Benigna set down the pot and sat with her, which was against the order of the house, and said very little, and stayed until the candle was out. In the morning the woman told Sarah in the kitchen that she had slept, and asked the girl's name, so as to put it in her prayers. *You would do better to ask to be put in hers,* Sarah said.

Twice the Elders proposed her name. The first time it was for a brother in the joinery, in 1813. The Lot said No. The second time, in the autumn of 1815, it was for a widowed schoolmaster at Lititz, in Pennsylvania, a good man with two small children, and Benigna, who was not supposed to know, knew. The Lot said No.

She went on carrying the dishes through November. She laughed as before. But she ate less, and then little, and by Christmas she was sending her plate back to Sarah as it had come. The town said it was the Lot. A girl twice refused by the Saviour, they said, and her sisters both settled. The town had nothing else to say it was. Sarah, who saw the plates, said only that the child was not grieving, whatever she was doing, and nobody had asked her.

In February Benigna went to bed in the room over the kitchen, where it was warm.

III. Over the Kitchen

The tavern · the second week of March 1816

Brother Rothe was at Friedland that day, eleven miles out, in the kitchen of the meeting house, with two hundred buns on boards and a married sister weeping because the coffee had boiled. A boy came on the tavern's mare. *Sister Benigna asks for her father.*

He left the buns and rode. It was eleven miles, and the whole way he thought of things he had meant to say to her at some time when the house was quieter. He tried to remember when he had last sat down in

the back room, and could not. He came up the back stairs with his hat still on.

She lay propped on the bolster, with her hair tied back. She had got very thin. Her eyes were clear, and she was looking at the door when he came through it, as if she had known to the minute how long the mare would take. Sarah was sitting by the bed with a basin and got up to give him the chair.

What is it, my dear daughter? What is it, Benigna?

What are you saying, little brother?

He took off his hat. He looked at Sarah, who looked at the basin.

You are wandering, child.

I am not wandering, little brother.

She said it kindly and without hurry, as she might have told him his coat was buttoned wrong. He sat down and took her hand, which weighed nothing.

Are you afraid, my daughter?

I am not afraid, little brother.

She said nothing else. She looked at him a moment longer with great good humor, and then she was not looking at him, and Sarah leaned across and closed her eyes.

Within the hour the trombones played from the church. That was how Salem learned of every death, before any word went round. Four brethren with their horns played three tunes. The first told the town that someone had gone home. The second was the tune of the departed one's choir, so that every person in the street, stopping with a bucket or a plane in hand, would know at least what kind of soul it was, a child or a widow or a married brother. The third was the first again. That afternoon the second tune was the Single Sisters'. People counted over in their minds which of the single sisters had been ill, and came to her quickly.

Brother Rothe heard it in the room over the kitchen. He knew every tune the trombones had. He sat with his hat on his knee and listened to them say that a single sister had gone home, and thought, they have it wrong. It was my daughter.

IV. The Single Sisters' Row

God's Acre · three days later

THEY READ HER LIFE IN THE CHURCH BEFORE THEY CARRIED her up the hill. Every brother and sister wrote one, or had it written, an account of the road they had come, and it was read over them at the end. Benigna's was a page and a half in her own round hand. It said she was born in the tavern in 1795 and had been a happy child. It said that in her sixteenth year, at her father's table, the Saviour had come so near that she had not since been able to find the place where she left off and His kindness began, and that she had tried to deserve the back room. It did not mention the Lot. The last lines, on her illness and her going, were added in another hand, as was the custom.

The burying ground at Salem lay along the ridge above the town, behind a row of cedars, and it was laid out by choirs. The married brethren lay in one square and the married sisters in another, the single brethren and the single sisters each in their own, and the little boys and the little girls. Within each square they lay in the order they had come, one after the next. Every stone was the same, a flat white square, set level in the grass, with the name and the two dates. No one in that ground lay beside a husband, or under a father's name. There was nothing on the hill to show that any of them had been related to one another at all.

He had buried his wife there seventeen years before and had thought it right and beautiful. He thought so now. He stood with the married brethren, as was the order, and watched his daughter go into the ground at the end of the single sisters' row, next to a seamstress of eighty-one she had hardly known, and he wept, and could not stop. People were surprised at it. He was a brother of long standing. He had stood at a great many gravesides with a dry and cheerful face and afterward seen to the coffee.

There was a lovefeast after the burial, as there generally was, and for once somebody else had counted the buns. They were eight short. He noticed it through his tears, and was ashamed of noticing.

He wept through that day and the next. On the third day he let the dinner go out to the back room without looking at it, and went up the street to the Single Sisters' House, and asked at the door for Sister Dorel.

V. Sister Dorel

The Single Sisters' House · the same day

Anna Dorothea Schumann had charge of the single sisters' souls. That was her office, and it had a name, Pflegerin, the one who tends. She was forty-four, a short, quick woman from Lititz who had come down the Wagon Road at twenty with her loom in pieces, and she was thirteen years younger than the man who stood in her doorway holding his hat. Once in four weeks, before each Communion, every sister in the choir came to her alone and told her how it stood with her heart. Sister Dorel had heard Benigna Rothe in that way some eighty times. She had written none of it down. For the last three years she had come away from those quarter hours with the feeling that it was she who had been heard.

She did not get up from the tape loom. She pointed him to the other stool.

Brother Rothe. You have been weeping, and you are weeping now. What is it?

Sister, my Benigna is dead.

Well, and why do you weep? Is there anyone in Salem who is not going home?

I know that. I have known it all my life. But she was such a modest girl, Sister, and so careful in everything. What I cannot bear is that she did not have her right mind at the end. She went out of the world talking nonsense.

What did she say to you?

He told her. He gave it word for word, his part and hers. *I called her my dear daughter, and she said, What are you saying, little brother? I said, You are wandering, child, and she said, I am not wandering, little brother. I asked her was she afraid. She said, I am not afraid, little brother. And then she was gone.*

Sister Dorel beat the weft down and let the shuttle lie.

Your daughter was not wandering.

Then why would she say such a thing?

Because you are her little brother. That is all. You came to the Saviour one Good Friday when you were forty, and you have stayed where He set you down, and it is a good place. I have nothing against it. Your daughter went on from there. She went on a long way. In the things that matter in this house she was older than you, Brother Rothe, by a great deal, and she knew it, and at the end she called you what you were to her.

Was that the reason?

That was the reason.

He sat a while with his hat. Outside a wagon went down toward the tavern.

Where is she now, Sister?

At home. Where it is glad.

She was glad here, he said slowly. *All the time she was among us, at the wall with that coffee pot, she went about glad. And now she has gone from here and come to where it is glad again.*

Yes. That is how it is with the ones who stay awake, Brother. In a choir house or in a tavern, it makes no difference. They are glad here and they are glad there. They look back on what they have done and are glad of it, and then they go where it is better and are gladder still. She found the place in her memory. It was one of the English hymns the boarding school girls sang, by an Englishman who had joined the Brethren. Benigna had liked to sing it over the dishpan.

Children of the heavenly King,
As we journey, sweetly sing;
Sing your Saviour's worthy praise,
Glorious in his works and ways.

We are traveling home to God,
In the way the Fathers trod;
They are happy now, and we
Soon their happiness shall see.

— John Cennick, 1742

Then she took up the shuttle. *Go and see to your table, little brother,* she said. He was down the steps and into the street before he heard what she had called him.

VI. Easter Morning

God's Acre · April 14, 1816

On the Saturday before Easter the people of Salem went up the hill with buckets and brushes and scrubbed every stone in the burying ground, and laid flowers on each, on all of them alike. It was a cold spring and there was not much, some daffodils, the first redbud, green box. Benigna had no stone yet. Her father laid his on the raw clay.

Before light on Easter morning the trombones went through the streets to wake the town. The congregation gathered in front of the church in the dark and heard it said that the Lord was risen, and answered, and then walked up the cedar avenue two and two behind the horns, some hundreds of people, into the burying ground, and stood among the stones in their choirs, facing east. It had been done so in Salem every year since the town was a clearing. The thing was timed, and the Brethren were good at timing. The sun was meant to come up over the ridge while they prayed for the ones who had gone that year.

Brother Rothe stood with the married brethren. Sarah stood at the edge, by the cedars, with the other Black sisters and brethren. Three years before, the Elders had ruled that the hill was closed to her. When her time came she would lie in the strangers' ground, at the far end of the street. He had thought nothing of the rule when it was made. He looked across at her now. He counted the years she had been in the Saviour's keeping, and then he counted his own.

The minister read the litany. It was long, and all of it known by heart. It was the whole of what they believed, said in the open air among the dead. Toward the end, as the edge of the sky went from gray to yellow, he came to the place.

And keep us in everlasting fellowship with our brethren, and with our sisters, who have entered into the joy of their Lord;

Also with the servants and handmaids of our Church, whom thou hast called home in the past year, and with the whole Church triumphant; and let us rest together in thy presence from our labors.

— Easter Morning Litany of the Moravian Church

The people answered, and sang, with the horns under them.

They are at rest in lasting bliss,
Beholding Christ our Saviour:
Our humble expectation is
To live with him forever.

— Easter Morning Litany of the Moravian Church

The sun came over the ridge. It came along the ground, as it does there, low and yellow through the cedars, and it lit the stones one row after another, the married sisters and then the little girls, and came last to the end of the single sisters' row, where the daffodils lay on the clay. Heinrich Rothe sang with the rest. His face was wet and he let it be. He was not weeping as he had wept in March.

• • •

There was a lovefeast at Bethania on Easter Monday, and they had sent to ask him. He sent back his paper of quantities, and word that the Bethania sisters could count buns as well as he could.

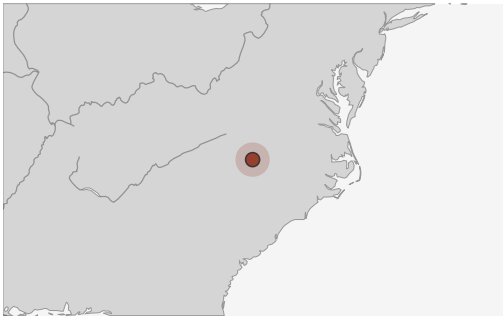
Two missionaries were in the back room that noon, a brother and his wife from the Cherokee country, gray with the road. Sarah had the dishes ready in the kitchen. He took them from her himself. He laid the cloth and carried in the soup, and set a bun at each place, and poured for the sister first because she was the elder. The jug of feathers stood on the sill. Then he stepped back against the wall with the coffee pot in both hands, where the plaster was worn smooth at the height of a girl's shoulder, and listened to them talk.

Background

The verse

> *The virtuous man is happy in this world, and he is happy in the next; he is happy in both. He is happy when he thinks of the good he has done; he is still more happy when going on the good path.*
>
> Dhammapada 18, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the great lay supporter Anāthapiṇḍika feeds two thousand monks a day in his house at Sāvatthī, but he is so much in demand to advise other donors that he cannot serve the monks himself. He appoints his eldest daughter, who reaches the first stage of awakening, marries and leaves, and then the second, who does the same. The youngest, Sumanā, reaches the second stage, does not marry, stops eating and sends for him. On her deathbed she calls him "younger brother" and dies. He goes weeping to the Buddha, sure that she died out of her mind, and is told that she spoke exactly: he had reached only the first stage, and she was his elder on the path. She has been reborn in the Tusita heaven. Read the full commentary story, or about Anāthapiṇḍika.



Salem, North Carolina

Salem, 1816

The Moravians, or Unity of the Brethren, bought the Wachovia tract in the North Carolina piedmont in 1753 and founded Salem in 1766 as a congregation town, in which the church owned the land and regulated trades, residence and marriage. Members were grouped by age, sex and marital state into "choirs," each with its own spiritual helper, and were buried by choir in God's Acre under identical flat stones. Each member left a memoir, or *Lebenslauf*, to be read at the funeral, and regularly "spoke" with the choir helper before Communion (see the Moravian Archives' glossary). Deaths were announced by a trombone choir, with a chorale that identified the choir of the departed. Marriages were submitted to the Lot, slips drawn by the Eld-

ers after prayer, which the Brethren took as the Saviour's own answer; the requirement was dropped for most American members in 1818. The lovefeast, a simple shared meal of buns and coffee served during a service of song, and the Easter sunrise service in the graveyard, held at Salem since 1772, are still kept. The tavern, rebuilt in brick in 1784, was set at the edge of town to keep outsiders apart; the Rothe family and the guest table are invented. Salem is preserved today as Old Salem in Winston-Salem.

The Moravians of Wachovia held people in slavery, most of them owned by the church itself and hired out, including to the tavern. Black Moravians were baptized and received as brothers and sisters, and at first worshipped and were buried alongside white members. The Elders began seating them separately in 1789, closed God's Acre to them in 1813, and in the 1820s set up a separate congregation, later St. Philips. Salem Academy and College has published an account of one enslaved Moravian family. John Cennick (1718–1755), who wrote the hymn, was an English evangelist who joined the Moravians in 1745. The Easter Morning Litany dates from 1749; the English text is the one printed in Philip Schaff's *Creeds of Christendom* (1877).

After the story of Sumanā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 18). The original. Scripture from the Easter Morning Litany of the Moravian Church (1749) and a hymn by John Cennick (1742). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

1.14

The Third Chair

Only the poor man counts his flock.
— Seneca, Letter 33, tr. Gummere (quoting Ovid)

C'est de même que je l'ai entendu conter, above the Androscoggin.

I. The Tuesday Table

Pontook Falls, New Hampshire · 2012–2017

Chief Lise Pelletier ran the Tuesday table at the VFW post on Main Street because the men would not come to anything called a group. She had tried calling it a group. Two men came, and one of them was the minister.

She had driven trucks in the Marines in the first Gulf war and come home to a town of two thousand people that had lived for a hundred years on the pulp mill in Berlin and had not yet worked out how to live without it. The mill shut in 2006. By 2012 the Pontook Falls police department was the chief, three officers and a cruiser with a quarter of a million miles on it. Mostly what they did was drive men home. She was forty-five. She had read Seneca since a lieutenant in Saudi Arabia left a paperback in a tent, and she now owned the three red volumes of the old Loeb edition, bought used in Hanover, the spines held together with packing tape.

On Tuesdays at seven she read one letter aloud, slowly, the way you would read a will. Then she asked one question and said nothing else. Some nights the men talked until ten. Some nights nobody said a word. They drank their coffee and went home, and she counted that a good night too.

Before anyone sat down, somebody set a chair for her at the end of the table. Nobody remembered who started it. Nobody else ever sat in it. The winter night she was out at a fatal on Route 16 and never came, eleven men sat around the empty chair for an hour and talked about the letter anyway.

Ray Lacasse and Kyle Brennan came to the table the same Tuesday, in November of 2012, and on paper they had nothing to say to each other. Ray was forty-eight. He had been a millwright at the pulp mill for twenty-two years and had plowed driveways and fixed snow machines since. At nineteen he had been at the Beirut airport the morning the barracks went down, and he had dug for two days, and that was all anybody at the post had ever got out of him about it. Kyle was twenty-three, two years out of Sangin, and had just been hired as a corrections officer at the new federal prison in Berlin. He talked fast. He had read more by twenty-three than Ray would read in his life, and he knew it, and he could not help letting you know it.

But they were the only two men at the table who did not drink, and after the second Tuesday they walked out to the lot together, and after that they were seldom seen apart. Kyle was at Ray's kitchen table most Sundays. They ran Ray's traps on the Upper Ammonoosuc and sat in an ice shack on the reservoir with nothing to say for six hours at a stretch. When Ray's wife Monique died in the spring of 2015, Kyle slept on the couch for a month. When Ray's son Danny died on a bathroom floor in Manchester in November of 2016, one of four hundred and eighty-five people the state lost to drugs that year, Kyle drove down and got him and drove him home.

Five years after their first Tuesday, they stayed after the table, in the fall of 2017, and asked the chief what the work was.

She folded her reading glasses. *There's two ways to do this. You can learn it. All of it, the Latin, the Greek if you want, every letter he wrote. Or you can do what it says. Both of those are good. Most men try both and do half of each.*

I'm fifty-three, Ray said. *I read a page and by the bottom the top's gone. I'll do the other one.*

I'll learn it, Kyle said.

She tore a card off the stack of three-by-fives she kept in her shirt pocket for parking tickets and wrote on it in square capitals and gave it to Ray. It said DO THE NEXT THING. Kyle she gave nothing, because he was already reaching for the red book.

II. The Hired Man

North Haverhill · 2017–2021

MONIQUE'S COUSIN GORDON PIKE HAD FORTY-FOUR HOLsteins in a tie-stall barn on the river flats below Route 10, a bad back, and nobody to milk. His children had gone to Concord and Charlotte and were not coming back. *Fourteen-eighty a hundredweight,* he told Ray, standing in the milk house that December with his hands under his armpits. *That was the summer before last. I lost money on every can of it. Half the farms in this valley sold out. I could pay you in a room and whatever's left.*

Ray sold the house in Pontook Falls for what it would bring. He took nothing much. His barn coat came out of the donation box at the post and had somebody else's name, GAUTHIER, stitched over the pocket. He moved into the old hired man's rooms over the milk house, two rooms and a hot plate, and at fifty-three he learned to milk.

Four-thirty in the morning and four-thirty in the afternoon. Dip, strip, wipe, attach. The pipeline overhead carried the milk through glass to the tank, and you could see it go by, white, over your head. He learned each cow by her name and her temper. He learned to read a heifer's tail and to pull a calf. He did not read anything. He was too tired to read, and it turned out he did not need to. He said very little. When people asked how he was, he said *Milking,* and that was the answer.

The spring after he came, a boy from Pontook Falls named Tyler Roy showed up in the dooryard with a duffel bag and one of the chief's three-by-five cards. The chief had arrested him twice. This card said YOU ARE NOT IN CHARGE OF THE WEATHER. Ray read it and put it in his coat and showed Tyler where the boots were.

After Tyler there were others. The chief sent some. The drug court at the county courthouse two miles up Route 10 sent some, once word got

around. Each of them came with a card in the chief's square printing, and each card said one thing, and Ray never asked what it meant. He stood beside them in the parlor at four-thirty and did the next thing, and they did it beside him. Some of them left in a week. Some stayed a year. Gordon watched from his kitchen window and said he had never seen so many grown men so careful with a cow.

They stayed clean, a good many of them. Not all. Ray went to the funerals of the ones who did not, in Gauthier's coat, and stood at the back, and drove home in time for the evening milking.

III. The Watch

The Millyard, Manchester · 2018–2021

Kyle quit the prison in 2018 and moved to Manchester, to a third-floor studio in one of the old Amoskeag mill buildings on the river, brick walls and maple floors still dark with a hundred years of loom oil. He bought two good cameras and a microphone on an arm and began to talk.

He was good at it. He would have told you so himself, but it was also true. He had read every one of the hundred and twenty-four letters twice, and Epictetus, and the Meditations in Greek with a dictionary propped open beside him. He could give you the three disciplines, the four passions, the difference between an impression and an assent. He could give them to a nineteen-year-old lance corporal in Jacksonville at two in the morning in words the boy could hold on to. He called the channel *The Watch.* He signed off every episode the same way: *Stand your watch.* When the pandemic closed the gyms and the bars in 2020 and young men all over the country sat alone in their rooms with their phones, they found him by the hundred thousand.

By the summer of 2021 he had five hundred and twenty thousand subscribers. He had eighteen chapters that met in VFW halls, church basements and the back rooms of breweries, from Bangor to Albany. Every one of them set out a chair at the end of the table that nobody sat in. Kyle had told them about the Tuesday table, and they liked the story. He sold

challenge coins stamped MEMENTO MORI. He kept his commonplace cards in a steel ammunition can, four thousand three-by-fives in his own small printing, sorted by author, and on camera he would sometimes reach into the can without looking and come up with the right one.

He answered every email himself. Three men that he knew of had put down a gun because of something he said. He did not forget that, and he did not let himself make too much of it. But he knew the subscriber count every morning before he knew the weather.

That August the eighteen chapters held their first Muster, a weekend at a function hall in Gorham, six miles from the post on Main Street, because that was where it began. Four hundred men came. On the Saturday afternoon four young men in clean jeans and barn boots came up to Kyle by the coffee urns. They had driven over from Haverhill. They had been to see the chief that morning to thank her, and the old men at the post, and now they had come to see him.

Ray says hello, Tyler Roy said. *He said to tell you.*

Ray! How is he? Kyle meant it. *What's he got you working on up there?*

Milking, mostly.

Kyle laughed. *No, what are you reading? Has he got you on the Enchiridion? Give me the first line. Some things are within our power.* He waited, smiling. *Come on. The dichotomy of control. Anybody.*

The four of them looked at each other. Tyler took a card out of his shirt pocket, worn soft as cloth, and looked at it, and put it back.

Cows don't care, one of the others said.

Kyle laughed again, and nobody laughed with him. They shook his hand and drove back to Haverhill for the evening milking. Kyle stood by the urns with his coffee going cold and thought about Ray, who could not get to the bottom of a page, who had never in five years of Tuesdays said one sentence that was not about the weather or a truck, who had taken a dead man's coat out of a donation box and gone off to the river flats and gathered strays. And they called him their teacher. Next year, Kyle thought, I'll have him up. On the stream. He can tell everybody what he knows.

IV. The Third Chair

Gorham · June 2022

Ray came over for the second Muster on a Saturday in June, the first day he had taken off the farm in four and a half years. Tyler and the others were milking. He parked in the function hall lot at ten in the morning in Gauthier's coat, though it was already warm. He found Kyle on the stage running cables and gave him the coat and his feed-store cap.

Watch these. I'm going up to see the chief.

He drove up to Pontook Falls in Gordon's truck and sat in the chief's office for half an hour. Then he went down Main Street to the post, where the old men were at the bar drinking coffee at eleven in the morning, the Korea men, the Vietnam men, the ones from his own war. He shook every hand. Then he drove back to Gorham.

Kyle had the stage ready. Two chairs, the same make and the same height. He had checked. He was not going to have it said he had put Ray in a lower chair. Then, without thinking, the way you put your keys in the same pocket, he set a third chair at the end of the table, and stood looking at it, and left it.

In her office that morning the chief had listened to Ray tell her, without any edge in it, that Kyle wanted to ask him some questions on the stream that afternoon. After he left she sat for a while with her hands flat on the desk. She knew Kyle. She knew what he would do in front of forty thousand people, and she knew he would not mean any harm by it. She also knew there are things a man can do in front of forty thousand people that he cannot take back, and that the one they are done to is not always the one who pays for them.

At two-thirty she got in the cruiser.

The hall was full. The stream was live, and the number in the corner of Kyle's laptop said forty-one thousand and climbing. Kyle had just finished introducing Ray (*the man who sat across from me at the Tuesday table for five years, my oldest friend in this*) when the side door opened and the chief came in in uniform with her hat in her hand. She walked up the

side aisle, climbed the three steps to the stage, and sat down in the third chair.

Chief, Kyle said.

Go ahead, she said. *I'm just on my rounds.*

V. That's Right

The same afternoon

But it was she who asked the questions, and Kyle let her, because it was her table.

She asked him what is in our power and what is not. He gave it to her in Greek and then in English. She asked him the four virtues, and he gave them. She asked him the three disciplines, the passions and their kinds, the reserve clause, the view from above, what Seneca meant by a day's accounts. He answered every one of them correctly, without a card, in good plain sentences, and the hall clapped, and in the corner of the laptop the chat ran faster than anyone could read it.

Then she said, *Kyle. When were you last afraid?*

He began to tell her what fear is. It is a judgment about a future evil, he said; the evil lies in the judgment, not in the thing. He went on in that way, well, for most of a minute.

When, she said.

He opened his mouth and nothing came. He was afraid at that moment and could not say so. Four hundred men watched him not say it.

She turned to Ray. *When were you last afraid?*

Tuesday, Ray said. *Two in the morning. A heifer calving backwards. I thought she'd die and the calf with her. Then I got my arm in up to here.* He touched his shoulder. *You can't be scared and have your arm in a cow. Not both at once. You have to pick.*

That's right, the chief said.

In the milk house in North Haverhill, Tyler Roy had his phone propped on the bulk tank so he could watch while he washed up. He said afterward, and the three others backed him, and so did Gordon Pike in his kitchen, that when she said it all forty-four cows in the barn lifted

their heads at once and bawled, and the swallows went out of the rafters and through the big door in one rush. In the chat, the same two words went by thousands of times, faster than the screen could hold them.

She asked Kyle who he was angry at. He gave her Seneca on anger, a brief madness, and the three ways to meet it, and named some officers he had served under.

She asked Ray.

The fella who sold Danny the stuff, Ray said. *I was. He's up at Berlin now, the federal. Kyle helped me get on his visiting list, before he quit there. You remember.* Kyle nodded. He had driven him up the first time. *I go up the first Saturday of the month. He's twenty-nine. They've got him learning to weld.*

Are you angry at him?

Ray thought about it honestly, the way he thought about everything. *Not that I can find.*

That's right, the chief said. And in North Haverhill the cows bawled again.

She asked Kyle what he wanted. He said he wanted to want nothing outside his own will, and quoted, and was right.

She asked Ray.

Rain Wednesday, Ray said. *Gordon's got second cut coming.*

That's right. The cows.

She asked Kyle who he was. He was a Marine, he said, a student, a teacher of young men, a man still trying. He spoke for a long time. All of it was true.

She asked Ray.

Hired man, Ray said.

That's right, she said, the fourth time. And this time it was not only the Pike barn. Every farm family on both sides of the Connecticut that day, in Haverhill and Bath and over the river in Newbury and Bradford, will tell you that at about a quarter to four on that Saturday afternoon every cow in the valley called out at once, in the barns and in the pastures, and the dogs answered from the dooryards. People came out onto their porches and looked up and down the river. They saw nothing and went back in.

VI. Other Men's Cows

The same afternoon · and July

In the front rows the chapter leaders had gone quiet in a way that was not respect. A man from the Albany chapter said it out loud, and the chat said it louder. Kyle knew all of it, every letter, every line, and the chief had not said *That's right* to him once. She had said it four times to an old man in a borrowed shirt who could not name the three disciplines.

What's the trouble? the chief said into the microphone, and the man from Albany told her.

She heard him out. Then she said, *Ray says he's the hired man. He's wrong about that. Kyle's the hired man. He's like a fella you pay to stand at the gate and count another man's cows through. He'll get the number right every time, and he won't get a glass of milk out of it. Ray milks his own.*

She took the first red volume out of her jacket, where it had been all along, and opened it at a page she had marked with a parking ticket, and read it the way she read on Tuesdays.

> *For a man, however, whose progress is definite, to chase after choice extracts and to prop his weakness by the best known and the briefest sayings and to depend upon his memory, is disgraceful; it is time for him to lean on himself. He should make such maxims and not memorize them. For it is disgraceful even for an old man, or one who has sighted old age, to have a note-book knowledge. "This is what Zeno said." But what have you yourself said? "This is the opinion of Cleanthes." But what is your own opinion? How long shall you march under another man's orders?*
>
> *— Seneca, Letter 33.7, tr. Gummere*

She turned the page.

> *But it is one thing to remember, another to know. Remembering is merely safeguarding something entrusted to the memory; knowing, however, means making everything your own; it means not depending upon the copy and not all the time glancing back at the master.*
>
> *— Seneca, Letter 33.8, tr. Gummere*

Then she closed the book, put on her hat, and went down the three steps and out the side door. The hall sat and listened to the cruiser pull out of the lot. Kyle did not sign off. After a while somebody in the booth ended the stream.

• • •

In July Kyle drove to North Haverhill with the ammunition can of cards on the passenger seat. He did not bring it in. He slept in Tyler's spare room over the milk house. At four-fifteen Ray knocked, and they walked down to the barn in the dark with the river fog lying on the flats.

The cows came in off the night pasture and went each to her own stanchion, without being told. Kyle stood by the door and counted them under his breath as they came, the way he had counted men off a helicopter.

Forty-four, Ray said, handing him the dip cup. *You can stop.*

Kyle took the cup. The first cow shifted her weight and let her breath out long and warm against his arm, and over their heads, in the glass line, the milk began to run toward the tank.

Background

The verses

> *The thoughtless man, even if he can recite a large portion (of the law), but is not a doer of it, has no share in the priesthood, but is like a cowherd counting the cows of others.*
>
> Dhammapada 19, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The follower of the law, even if he can recite only a small portion (of the law), but, having forsaken passion and hatred and foolishness, possesses true knowledge and serenity of mind, he, caring for nothing in this world or that to come, has indeed a share in the priesthood.*
>
> Dhammapada 20, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two friends from Sāvatthī go forth together. After five years, one, who has gone forth late in life, takes up the duty of meditation, goes off to the forest in rag robes and becomes an arahant with many pupils. The other takes up the duty of study, learns the Three Baskets by heart and teaches five hundred monks in eighteen communities. When the forest elder's pupils send greetings, the scholar scoffs that the old man does not know a four-line verse, and resolves to question him. Foreseeing that this would ruin the scholar, the Buddha comes as if on his rounds and sits in the seat always kept ready for him. He asks both monks questions. The scholar answers everything about the meditative absorptions, but nothing about the paths; the elder answers every question, and the Buddha praises him four times while the gods applaud. To the scholar's offended pupils he says their teacher is like a man who tends cows for wages, while the elder enjoys the products of the cow as his own. Read the full commentary story.

Gorham and North Haverhill, New Hampshire

New Hampshire, 2012–2022

Berlin, in the North Country, was a paper town for more than a century, and much of it still speaks New England French. Fraser Papers closed the Berlin pulp mill in 2006, and the town later took a federal prison, opened in 2012. New Hampshire's per-capita overdose death rate was among the highest in the country in these years: 485 people died of drugs in 2016 and 487 in 2017. The state's dairies were going under at the same time. In 2016, as drought set in and milk fell to $14.80 a hundredweight, 19 of the state's 120 dairy farms closed. Haverhill, on the Connecticut River, is the Grafton County seat; the county offices and courthouse stand on Route 10 just

north of North Haverhill. Pontook Falls, the Pike farm and every person in the story are invented.

Seneca wrote his 124 moral letters to Lucilius at the end of his life. Richard Mott Gummere's translation of them appeared in the Loeb Classical Library, whose Latin volumes are bound in red, beginning in 1917. Stoicism has had a long modern revival: the founders of cognitive therapy traced their method back to the Stoics, and the Navy pilot James Stockdale credited Epictetus with carrying him through years as a prisoner in Hanoi. That made it a philosophy many American servicemen and veterans took up, and in the 2010s and 2020s it found a large online audience. Ray dug at the Beirut barracks, where 241 American servicemen were killed in October 1983. Kyle's studio is in the Millyard, the brick mill buildings of the Amoskeag Manufacturing Company, which went bankrupt in 1935.

After the story of the two monastic friends from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 19 and 20). The original. Scripture from Seneca's *Moral Letters to Lucilius*, Letter 33, in Richard M. Gummere's translation (Loeb, 1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 2

On Earnestness

2.1

Castile Roses

> *Blessed is the man that heareth me, and that watcheth daily at my gates, and waiteth at the posts of my doors.*
> *— Proverbs 8:34*

Así lo oí decir, along the Río de Santa Cruz.

I. The Red Blanket

The Truchas peaks, New Mexico · the 1740*s*

Don Bernardo Quintana was the richest man between the Chama and the Truchas. One morning in March his wife doña Isabel sat with him in the sun of the placita, heavy with their first child, wrapped in his red Saltillo blanket, playing with his silver ring, which she had slipped off his finger. A shadow went over the yard. Don Bernardo looked up and ran for the door, and doña Isabel, who was eight months along, could not run.

The old people in the valley say it was an eagle, and some say it was something worse. It saw the red blanket and took it for meat. It came down and closed its feet on her and carried her up over the walls, over the river and the black mesa, into the mountains, and set her in the fork of a great yellow pine where it kept the bones of the lambs it took. She kept silent while it flew, knowing it would drop her, and when it settled and bent its head to her she clapped her hands and screamed, and it flew off.

That night, in a storm, alone in the tree, she had her baby. He was born as the clouds broke and the morning star came out over the mountain, and she called him Lucero for the star.

Below the pine lived a hermit named Anselmo. He had been a rich man in Taos, and he and his oldest friend had given it all up and gone to live on two mountains facing each other, and every Saturday night each lit a fire so the other would know he was alive. One Saturday the other fire did not burn. A week later a stranger came up the trail and asked Anselmo if anything troubled him up there. Only the wild horses, Anselmo said, that came down at night and trampled his beans. The stranger gave him a guitar with three courses of strings and taught him three songs. Play the first, he said, and the horses will run and never look at you. Play the second and they will run looking back. Play the third and the stallion that leads them will come and offer you his back. Then he went down the trail, and Anselmo understood whose fire had gone out.

On wet days Anselmo did not go into the woods for piñones. He went to the foot of the eagle's pine and gathered bones for broth. He was picking up bones when he heard a baby crying above him.

Who are you?

A woman.

Come down.

Are you a Spaniard? I can't come down to anybody.

I am.

Then say me the Salve Regina.

He said it in Latin, all of it, and she let him climb up and carry the boy down, and she came down after by herself and would not let him take her hand. He kept her in his hut and fed her honey and never came near her. But she knew that nobody in the world knew where she was except this old man, and if he tired of them and went off up the mountain, she and the boy would die there. So one night she let her hair down and let him see her, and after that they lived together as man and wife.

Years later, reading the stars one winter night, Anselmo said, *Don Bernardo Quintana of the Cañada is dead.* She wept. *Everybody dies,* he said. *I know it,* she said. *I'm crying because my son should have had his father's house and his father's land, and now he's a boy in the mountains with nothing.* So Anselmo gave the boy the guitar and taught him the three songs.

His mother gave him the red blanket and the silver ring and the names of his father's mayordomo and vaqueros. When the wild horses came down to drink, he sat in the lowest branch of the pine and played the third song, and a dun stallion came and stood under him, and he got down onto its back and told it in its ear who he was. The stallion called the herd. It called again, and the old ones and the foals dropped back. It called a third time, and he rode down out of the Truchas at the head of two hundred wild horses.

At his father's gate they would not open. Until they knew whether their lady was alive or dead, they said, they would give the house to no one. He said the names of the mayordomo and the vaqueros, and held up the red blanket and the ring, and they opened the gate. From that day the whole valley called him el Lucero.

II. The Luck-Child

Santa Cruz de la Cañada · the 1750s

A WOMAN WHO LIVED BY MEN AT THE EDGE OF THE PLAZA HAD a son, and because a son was no use to her she put him in an old winnowing basket and left him on the dung heap. The dogs and the crows came and sat around him in a ring all morning, and not one of them touched him. A man going by saw the ring of dogs and took the boy home.

That same day the padre told don Cosme Baca, who ran the mule trains to Chihuahua, that by the almanac a boy born in the Cañada that day would be the richest man in the valley. Don Cosme's wife was near her time. He sent his servant Juana to buy the boy, meaning to marry him to his daughter if she had one. She had a son.

So don Cosme gave Juana her orders. She laid the baby across the gate of the corral at dawn, where the oxen would come out over him, and the lead ox, that always came out last, came out first that morning and stood over the child with its four feet around him while the herd went by on either side. The herdsman took him home. Juana bought him back. She laid him in the road in front of the carretas leaving for Chihuahua, and the oxen of the first cart threw off their yoke and would not go on,

though the drover yoked them again and again until the sun came up. The drover took him home. Juana bought him back. She left him in the brush behind the camposanto for the coyotes, and a nanny goat went into the chamisa and knelt down over him and nursed him, and the goatherd took him home. Juana bought him back. She carried him up the cliff over the river they call the Robbers' Leap and threw him off, and he fell into a willow thicket as if into a feather bed, on the very morning a basket-maker had come with his son to cut withes there. The basket-maker took him home. Juana bought him back.

They called him Ventura, the lucky one. The old women said the dogs knew him, and the oxen, and the goat.

When he was twelve don Cosme went to the man who burned lime by the river and paid him to kill the boy he would send the next morning and put him in the kiln. In the morning he sent Ventura down with a message. *Tell him to finish the job I gave him yesterday.* On the way Ventura passed don Cosme's own son losing at knucklebones in the plaza. *Where are you going? To the lime-burner, with a message. Let me take it. I've lost everything I have to these boys. Stay and win it back for me.* So don Cosme's own son went to the kiln.

Don Cosme came running down the river road at evening with his hands in the air. *Don't! Don't!* And the lime-burner said, *Be quiet, patrón. It's done.*

After that don Cosme wrote a letter to his mayordomo at the rancho on the Chama. *This is my bastard. Kill him and throw him down the well.* He pinned it inside Ventura's coat, because Ventura could not read, and told him to eat on the way at his compadre's house. The compadre's daughter Rosalía had been taught her letters by the padre. She took the letter from the coat of the young man asleep in her mother's kitchen, read it, burned it, and wrote another in don Cosme's hand. *This is my son Ventura. Marry him to the daughter of my compadre. Build him a house in the middle of the rancho with a wall around it, and set men to guard him.* The mayordomo did all of it and sent word to the Cañada that it was done.

Don Cosme took to his bed with the bloody flux. He sent for Ventura to tell him before witnesses that he would not leave him a single real.

Rosalía had told Ventura where to stand. When don Cosme opened his mouth to say *I will not give him*, he said, *I give him,* and died, and el Lucero, who was the law in that valley, gave Ventura everything don Cosme had. Ventura set a kitchen at his gate, and every day at noon he fed whoever came.

III. The Fence

The Camino Real · winter 1780–81

VENTURA HAD A FRIEND HE HAD NEVER MET, DON FERMÍN Ledesma of El Paso del Norte. For twenty years they had sent each other presents by the caravans, wine and brandy north, wool and piñones south.

In the fall of 1780 the smallpox came up the river from Mexico. It went through El Paso and through every pueblo on the Rio Grande. In don Fermín's house the servants died first, and then the children, and when there were three of them left, don Fermín and his wife and their daughter Paz, they broke a hole through the back wall of the house and went out that way, and not by the door the sickness had come in, and started north to find Ventura.

They came into the Cañada in January, black from sun and wind, so starved they could hardly stand, and lay down in a shed by the road. Don Fermín would not go to his friend's door looking like a beggar. They would eat a few days at the kitchen at his gate first. So Paz, who had been brought up never to go out of the house without her mother, covered her face with her rebozo and stood in line with the beggars and the widows and the children of the smallpox. *How many*? *Three.* They gave her three bowls. Her father ate all of his, and could not keep it, and died before morning. The next day she asked for two, and her mother ate, and died. The third day she asked for one.

The man with the ladle was Ventura's steward Matías. *So today,* he said, *you finally know how much your belly holds.*

She told him why. He put the ladle down in the pot and cried in front of everybody and took her home and called her his oldest daughter.

The kitchen at Ventura's gate was a shoving mob every noon that winter, and the shouting carried to Ventura's house across the plaza, and he liked to hear it. *That's my kitchen,* he would say. Paz said to Matías, *Why do you let them fight like that? There's no stopping it. Put a fence around the yard, and two gates, each wide enough for one, and have them come in by one and go out by the other.* He did it, and after that there was no more shouting.

After three days Ventura asked Matías if the kitchen had closed. Matías told him about the fence, and then about the girl who had thought of it, and then the whole story from the beginning. *Ledesma's girl? Why didn't you tell me? My friend's daughter is my daughter.* He took her into his house and kissed her on the head and gave her every girl he had taken in that winter to keep her company. There were so many of them that people in the plaza said Paz had five hundred women.

• • •

On the feast of San Juan, when the women of the valley go down to bathe in the river, and girls who never go out of their houses walk through the plaza with all the world looking, Paz and her women went down to the Santa Cruz. El Lucero saw them from his roof.

Whose dancers are those?

Nobody's dancers, patrón. That's Ledesma's daughter. Ventura's girl.

He sent for her that afternoon. Ventura sent back that he did not give away girls to have them talked about. El Lucero's men nailed Ventura's doors shut and put him and his wife out in the road. When Paz came up from the river she found them sitting there.

Father, don't argue. Send word that I'll go, with my women.

IV. The White Horse

The Río Abajo · 1782

Don Ignacio Saavedra, whom they called el Bravo, ran his sheep from Bernalillo to the Puerco, and one day he asked his men whether anybody on the river was as grand as he was. Only el Lucero of

THE CAÑADA, THEY SAID, WHO HAD A GUITAR THAT CALLED horses, and more horses than God. He meant to take him. Nobody could, they said. But el Lucero would ride a long way for a good horse.

So el Bravo had a stallion built out of cottonwood and hide, white as the snow on the Truchas, with men inside it to walk it, and set it loose by the hot springs at Ojo Caliente. When el Lucero heard of it he rode out after it and played the third song, and the white horse did not stop, because it had no ears. He rode on alone after it, faster than his men could follow, and el Bravo's riders closed in from both sides.

El Bravo locked him in his torreón and feasted for three days, until el Lucero sent down word that a man who takes his enemy alive must let him go or kill him, and getting drunk was neither. El Bravo came up. He would let him go, he said, for the songs. El Lucero said he would teach them to anyone who knelt to him first. El Bravo said he would sooner have him hanged. *Hang me, then. You're master of my neck. You're not master of my songs.*

So el Bravo told el Lucero there was a hunchbacked woman in his house who would kneel to learn them, behind a blanket so he would not have to look at her. And he told his daughter Dolores there was a leper in the tower who knew a great secret, and she must learn it from behind a blanket so she would not catch his sickness. For a month he played on one side of the blanket and she tried on the other. One day she could not get it right, and he shouted, *Thick-lipped hunchback, I'll knock your teeth in!* and she shouted back, *Leper! Who are you calling a hunchback?* and he lifted the blanket.

After that there were no more lessons. She went to her father and said the secret needed a root that had to be dug by starlight, so they would need a door and a horse at any hour. He gave her the door and the horses. One night when el Bravo was at a wedding in Bernalillo, they loaded his gray she-mule with two sacks of pesos, gold and silver, and took his two mares, and rode north. When el Bravo's men came after them el Lucero opened the sack of gold and scattered it in the road, and the riders got down to fill their hats, and when they came on again he scattered the sil-

ver. By morning he was with his own men at the Cañada. Dolores came into his house as his second wife.

V. The Footprint

Taos · 1783

In those years there was a man the valley called el Hermano. He had been born among some people out on the plains, nobody knew which, and taken as a child by the Comanches, and ransomed at the Taos fair by a family of Abiquiú who raised him to work for them for twenty years and taught him the catechism. When his years were served he went to live alone in a hut below the black mesa by the river. He belonged to no brotherhood and took no vows. People came to sit with him anyway, and some of them stayed.

Every winter a band of men who lived summers in the mountains came down to the Cañada, and three rich men, Ventura and don Gaspar Gallegos and don Lázaro Tafoya, kept them until spring. One fall, coming down, they sat under a great cottonwood by the river, and the oldest thought how good a drink of water would be, and there was water. He thought of food, and there was food. *Who's there?* A peon in his work clothes came out of the trunk. He had worked for a family in Abiquiú that followed el Hermano, and one Holy Thursday he came in from the fields at dark, starving, and found the whole house keeping the fast. He kept it with them, though it was late, and the cramps took him, and he died at dawn on Good Friday. Since then, he said, he had lived in the tree.

Who is this Hermano? they asked, and made him say the name three times, and went down to the hut below the mesa and never went back up the mountain. That spring the three rich men each built el Hermano a little chapel of adobe on his own land, and el Hermano kept one day in each, and on each day took his bread at that man's door.

• • •

Up in Taos lived a Spaniard named don Melitón Mondragón with a daughter, Clara, who was the most beautiful girl in the north. Every

young man with a horse had asked for her, and don Melitón had sent every one of them off, cursing, as not good enough. One morning he saw el Hermano on the road below the pueblo and stood still. He was looking at the most beautiful man he had ever seen.

Wait here, he said. *I have a daughter for you.*

El Hermano said nothing. Don Melitón brought Clara back in her silk, with her mother and half of Taos behind them. El Hermano was gone. Where he had stood there was one footprint in the dust.

Doña Clara the elder, the girl's mother, had been raised on the frontier and could read a track as well as any scout in the governor's service. She knelt and looked at it a long time. *Melitón, this is no track of a man who wants anything. A man who wants is up on his toes. A man who hates comes down hard on his heel. This one wants nothing. You see snakes in the water jar,* said her husband, and then he looked up and saw el Hermano standing in the field.

Hermano, I give you my daughter.

El Hermano said he would tell him something first. He said that when he was young he had gone out into the desert to pray, and the devil's daughters had come to him there, as girls and as women, as everything a man could want. *I didn't want them,* he said. *What is it, a bag of piss and dung? I wouldn't touch it with my foot.*

Don Melitón and his wife gave away what they had and went to live by the river near el Hermano. Clara had heard herself called a bag of dung in front of half of Taos. Her uncle, don Severo, took her down to the Cañada in her silk and showed her to el Lucero, and el Lucero took her for his third wife. From the day she came into his house she waited for el Hermano to walk by.

El Lucero kept each of his wives in her own house around the great placita and spent seven days with each, in turn, and the padre at Santa Cruz preached against it every Lent and took his tithes anyway.

VI. Castile Roses

The great placita · summer 1783

El Lucero gave Paz eight reales a week to buy roses for the altar in her room. Her servant Chona went for them, a hunchbacked genízara who had been bought at the Taos fair as a girl. She bought them from Simón, the gardener of the three rich men, who grew the old roses of Castile along his ditch, and every week she paid him four reales and kept four.

One day Simón said, *No roses yet. El Hermano is eating at my house today. Stay, and you can have what's left over after.* So Chona stood in Simón's doorway while el Hermano ate his bread and said his thanks. What he said was very short. She went home with eight reales' worth of roses.

Did the patrón give us double this week?

No, señora. Every other week I kept four reales for myself.

Why not this week?

Because I heard el Hermano.

Paz did not call her a thief. She said, *You've had a drink of something. Give me some.* She had water heated and bathed Chona herself and put a new skirt on her and her own rebozo, and sat her in her own chair with her painted fan, and Chona told them everything el Hermano had said, word for word, to Paz and all her women. When she was done they said, *From now on, don't take anything. Be our mother. Go every day and hear him and come back and tell us.* Chona did, every day, so faithfully that el Hermano said later there was no one, man or woman, who had his words by heart the way she did.

The women wanted to see him. *Señora, this is a rich man's house,* Chona said. *You got in. You don't get out. Then what can we do? Make holes in the walls.*

So they dug through the adobe with spindles and kitchen knives, holes just big enough for an eye and a hand. When el Hermano went by on the road to the rich men's doors they stood at the holes and looked, and put their hands out through the walls holding roses.

VII. The Guitar

The great placita · autumn 1783

Clara Mondragón saw the holes and found out what they were for, and went to el Lucero. *Paz and her women are cutting holes in your walls. In a few days they'll kill you.* He did not believe her. The third time she told him he went and saw the holes, and said nothing, and had them filled with adobe and new windows set in all the rooms, small, and high up in the wall, so that a woman inside could see the sky and nothing else. That is why the old houses in the Cañada have their windows so high, people say.

Then Clara paid the idlers of the plaza to follow el Hermano. *Thief,* they shouted, *Comanche, dog, mule, devil, you're going to hell.* His companion, a young man named Cruz who carried his water jar, said, *Hermano, let's go somewhere else. Where? To Santa Fe. And if they shout at us in Santa Fe? Then to Albuquerque. And there?* Cruz had no answer. *Trouble that starts in one place has to be settled in that place,* el Hermano said. *I'm like a horse in a fight. The arrows come from every side. It's my work to stand.* And he gave Cruz a line to hold on to.

> *Take all that shall be brought upon thee: and in thy sorrow endure, and in thy humiliation keep patience.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 2:4*

Seven days, he said. On the eighth day the idlers were quiet.

So Clara turned to the women. One night when el Lucero was drinking El Paso brandy, her uncle brought eight live cocks and eight dead ones, and she paid the page, and the page carried the live cocks in. Clara said, *Send them to Paz's women, they have nothing to do, let them kill them and cook them for you.* The women sent back that since they had heard el Hermano they did not wring the neck of anything, not even a hen's. *Then tell them to cook them for el Hermano,* said Clara, and el Lucero sent that word, and the page carried them the eight dead cocks instead, and the women took them at the door and thanked him. *You see?* said Clara. *For you, nothing. For him, anything.* El Lucero still said nothing.

He always carried his guitar, the old one with three courses that had come down out of the Truchas with him, and there was a crack in its belly beside the sound hole. Clara had her uncle bring her a rattlesnake with its fangs dipped in poison, and she put it inside the guitar and stopped the hole with a bunch of Castile roses. On the morning el Lucero was to go to Paz for his seven days, Clara told him she had dreamed something terrible, and begged him three times not to go. When he went anyway she went with him.

At Paz's house he ate, and lay down, and set the guitar by the pillow. Clara walked back and forth in the room. As she passed the bed she pulled out the roses. The snake had been three days in the dark without food, and it came out over the strings and coiled on the bed beside his face and sang.

Clara screamed. *I told you! I told you and you wouldn't listen! What don't these women get from you? And this is how they pay you!*

El Lucero took down the horn bow he had brought home from a fight on the plains and strung it and fitted an arrow. Paz stood in front of him, and her women stood behind her in one line, and she said to them, *Hold nothing against him. Nothing against her. Love them both the way you love yourselves.*

He loosed the arrow at her breast. It stopped in the air between them and turned and came back the way it had gone, and fell at his feet. The people who were there said that it went into his heart all the same, by another road.

He threw the bow down and knelt. *Protect me, Paz. I don't know where I am.*

Not me, she said. *Go to the one I go to.*

He went down to the hut below the mesa that day and knelt there, and when he came back he told Paz to ask him for anything. She asked that el Hermano come to her house so that she and her women could hear him. El Hermano said he could not always be in one place. He sent Cruz every day instead.

One day, when Cruz had talked to them a long time, the women brought him five hundred new blankets of the valley's wool, striped, still

smelling of the dye pot. El Lucero saw his wives with their shoulders bare in October and went to find out why.

What will you do with five hundred blankets?

Keep what we need, patrón, and give the rest to those whose blankets are worn out.

And their old ones?

They give them to people whose blankets are worse, who make covers of them for their beds. When the covers wear thin they weave them into jerga for the floors. When the jerga wears through they cut it up and mix it with the mud and straw to plaster the walls.

El Lucero sent Cruz five hundred more.

VIII. The Morning Star

The great placita · Lent 1784

Clara could think of nothing else. On a day when el Lucero had ridden out to his sheep camps on the Chama, she sent her uncle into Paz's house. He opened the storerooms, soaked rags in tallow and piñon pitch, and began to wind them around the posts of the portal and the ends of the vigas. Paz's women came out to see. *The patrón wants the wood cured,* he told them. *Who knows why they do anything in a rich man's house. Go in, ladies, you'll get pitch on your skirts.* When they had all gone into their rooms he barred the doors from outside and set fire to the rags one after another and walked away.

Paz called through the walls to her women. *Who knows how many times women like us have burned. In this valley, in the raids, in every country there ever was, all the way back. Watch.* She did not say watch what. Chona was at Simón's that morning, and so she lived to say that from the road she could hear them through the high windows, praying, not screaming, until the roof came down.

Cruz and the mountain men brought the news to el Hermano at noon.

Paz's house burned with all her women in it. What will become of them?

Not one of them is lost, said el Hermano. *Each one of them received what was hers.* And that was all he said that day.

• • •

El Lucero came at a gallop when he saw the smoke and found the roof in. He sat in the ashes until night. He knew who had done it, and that she would never tell him if he asked. So in front of his household he said, *Every day of my life I've been afraid of that woman and her holes in the walls. Tonight I'll sleep. Whoever did this loved me.*

Clara was standing by. *I did it,* she said. *Who else? I sent my uncle.*

He said no one in the world loved him the way she did, and she should send for all her family, to be honored. They came from Taos, all of them, and others who had paid her uncle to be counted among her cousins. When they were all inside his gates he had pits dug waist-deep in the plaza and stood them in them, and filled the pits, and heaped straw around them and set it on fire. When the fire had burned down, he had them broken with the iron plow, the only one in the valley. He had Clara held, and cut pieces of her flesh away with a knife, and fried them in oil on a brazier in front of her, and made her eat them.

The mountain men said to el Hermano that it was not right for women who loved God so much to die like that. If you look at this life alone, he said, it is not right. Then he told them a story. Once, he said, in some country, some women who had been bathing in a cold river came out shivering and saw a heap of brush and set it on fire to warm themselves. When the brush burned down they saw a holy man sitting inside it, praying. They were afraid the lord they served would kill them for it. So they brought more wood from all around and piled it on him, and poured oil on it, and went away. *I don't know where that was,* el Hermano said. *I don't know when.*

Later the mountain men argued by the river. Paz and her women burned in their house. Clara Mondragón and all her people were burned in the plaza and broken with the plow. Which of them were alive and which were dead?

El Hermano heard them. *Clara was dead the whole time she was walking around,* he said. *Paz and her women are alive. People who watch don't die.* And he said the rest of it from the old books.

> *For she that liveth in pleasures, is dead while she is living.*
>
> *— 1 Timothy 5:6*

> *Blessed is the man that heareth me, and that watcheth daily at my gates, and waiteth at the posts of my doors. He that shall find me, shall find life, and shall have salvation from the Lord: But he that shall sin against me, shall hurt his own soul. All that hate me love death.*
>
> *— Proverbs 8:34–36*

El Lucero never had the house roofed again. The walls stood in the great placita for years, black inside, with the small windows set high where he had put them.

Chona went there every morning while it was still dark. In summer she carried roses from Simón's ditch and set them along the sill of the high window in the room that had been Paz's. In the winter she stood on the fallen vigas and looked out through that window at the morning star over the Truchas, which was the only thing it showed.

Background

The verses

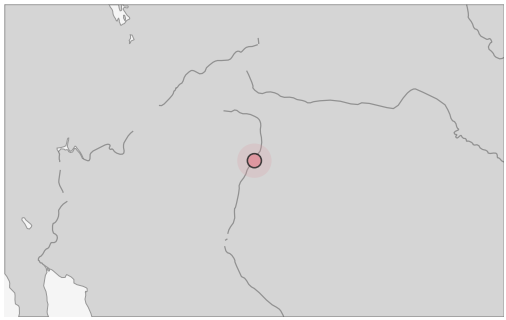
> *Earnestness is the path of immortality (Nirvana), thoughtlessness the path of death. Those who are in earnest do not die, those who are thoughtless are as if dead already.*
>
> Dhammapada 21, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Those who are advanced in earnestness, having understood this clearly, delight in earnestness, and rejoice in the knowledge of the Ariyas (the elect).*
>
> Dhammapada 22, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *These wise people, meditative, steady, always possessed of strong powers, attain to Nirvana, the highest happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 23, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The longest story in the commentary is a cycle about King Udena of Kosambī and his court. Udena is born in a tree after a monster bird carries off his pregnant mother, grows up with a hermit who gives him a lute that charms elephants, and rides

home on an elephant to claim his throne. The foundling Ghosaka survives seven attempts on his life by the rich man who bought him. The orphan Sāmāvatī, named for the fence she builds around an almshouse, becomes one of Udena's three chief queens; another, Vāsuladattā, he wins while held prisoner by her father, who lured him with a wooden elephant; the third, Māgandiyā, comes to hate the Buddha after he refuses her in marriage with a scornful verse about the body. Sāmāvatī's hunchbacked maid Khujjuttarā hears the Buddha while buying flowers and teaches the queen's women. Māgandiyā hires men to revile the Buddha, frames the women with dead cocks and a snake hidden in Udena's lute, and when the arrow Udena shoots at Sāmāvatī turns back, she has their house set on fire with all of them inside. Udena punishes her and her kin with fire, plow and knife. Asked which of these women are alive and which are dead, the Buddha speaks verses 21–23. Read the full commentary story.



Santa Cruz de la Cañada, New Mexico

The Cañada, 1780-84

Spanish New Mexico hung off the north end of the Camino Real de Tierra Adentro, the road of some 1,590 miles from Mexico City that was used from 1598 to 1882. Governor Diego de Vargas reestablished the villa of Santa Cruz de la Cañada in 1695, and its church was built between 1733 and 1748. Trade ran south by mule train and cart to Chihuahua, and so did the wine and brandy of El Paso del Norte, hundreds of barrels of it in a good year. Down the same road, the smallpox epidemic that swept North America in those years left the Valley of Mexico in 1779 and reached El Paso and points north in 1780, killing around 5,000 Pueblo people upriver.

Genízaros were detribalized Native people, most of them captives taken or bought from Comanche, Apache, Navajo and other nations and ransomed into Spanish households, where they typically owed ten to twenty years of service and were taught the Catholic faith. By 1793 they may have made up a third of the colony's people. In 1754 Governor Vélez Cachupín gave 34 genízaro families a land grant at Abiquiú on the Chama in return for defending the frontier, and it became the archetypal geníz-

aro settlement. On the feast of San Juan, June 24, the people of the northern valleys still keep old traditions of bathing in the streams, and the rivers and acequias are blessed.

After the story of Udena and Sāmāvatī from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 21–23). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.2

Paid in Rice

> *The reward of humility is the fear of the LORD, even riches, and honour, and life.*
> *— Proverbs 22:4*

Assim o ouvi, along the Bay in Charles Town.

I. The Wall

Charles Town, South Carolina · January 1760

Moses Valverde bought deerskins from the packhorse men who came down out of the Cherokee hills, and indigo from the planters on the Santee, and he sold both to London. In twenty years of it he had become one of the richest Jews between New York and the Spanish islands. He had a house on Elliott Street with a brick kitchen in the yard behind it and a fig tree against the back wall, and he kept his money in gold, in the ground, because his own father had left Lisbon in a single night with nothing but what was sewn into the lining of his coat.

The smallpox came down to the town that winter with the soldiers coming home from the Cherokee war. By the middle of January nobody on Elliott Street was counting funerals anymore, and the carts went by at night.

In the Valverde house it went the way the old women always said it went. First the ones who carry the water, then the ones who give the orders. Jemmy, who was eleven and fetched water from the pump on the corner, took sick first, and his mother Phibbah nursed him in the loft over the kitchen and buried him on a Monday, and on the Thursday she was lying where he had lain. Then the mistress. Then the master.

David was fourteen. His father would not let him past the door of the bedroom, so he stood in the doorway, and his father and mother looked at him from the big bed with their faces already changed, and his mother wept, and his father talked. He talked the way he talked to captains, quickly, with the important part last.

Listen to me. With this sickness the ones who live are the ones who go. Don't stay for us. Go up the country and keep going and don't come back until it's finished and finished twice. Under the kitchen hearth, the third brick from the left side of the fire-back, two feet down, there's an iron pot. Everything is in it. When you come back, you dig it up and you live on it. Say it back to me.

David said it back, the third brick, two feet down, crying so hard he could hardly say it.

There was no going out the front. Nobody in Charles Town that month would let a boy from a sick house pass in the street. So Scipio, who drove Moses Valverde's dray and slept over the stable, took the iron bar from the dray and pried four courses of soft old brick out of the back wall behind the fig tree, and made a hole there, and put his big hand flat on the boy's back and pushed him through it into the alley, and handed his coat after him.

Go on, Scipio said. *Don't look at the house.*

He went out over the Neck in the dark, past the last farms, and up the Broad Path into the pines. Behind him the town lay along its two rivers with a few lights in it and the steeple of St. Philip's white against the sky, and he did not look at it.

He was gone twelve years. He hired out to Germans on the Congaree, who fed him well and worked him to the bone and taught him to swear in their language. He packed skins for a trader over the mountains to the Cherokee towns after the peace. He hunted. He slept on the ground more nights than not. He lost count of the Sabbaths, but he never lost count of the years, and he never once said the words out loud again, though he said them in his head nearly every night before he slept. The third brick. Two feet down.

II. The Woodsman

Charles Town · the spring of 1772

He came back down the Broad Path in a hunting shirt and leggings, with his hair to his shoulders and a beard that had never seen a razor, and nobody in Charles Town knew him. The town had grown. There was a new Exchange at the foot of Broad Street with a cupola on top of it, and ships so thick at the wharves that the masts looked like a burnt wood.

The house on Elliott Street was gone. A fire had taken that end of the street some years back, and since there was no heir anyone could find, the lot had gone into Chancery, and the lawyers had let it sit. Weeds stood in the yard as high as his chest. The fig tree had grown wild over the hole in the back wall, which nobody had ever closed. The brick kitchen stood with no roof, and its chimney stood above it, black inside.

He went in by the old hole that night with a borrowed spade. The third brick from the left. He lifted the hearth bricks one by one and laid them in a row in the order he took them up, and he dug, and at two feet the spade rang on iron. The pot was just where they had left it. Inside, wrapped in oilcloth that was still sound, the gold lay as if somebody had put it there that afternoon: Portuguese joes and half-joes, Spanish doubloons, stacks of them, and a paper in his father's hand on the inside of the lid with the sum written on it in Portuguese.

He sat back on his heels in the dark and thought.

Nobody here knew him. If a man in a hunting shirt walked up to the Exchange with a bag of gold, nobody would believe a word he said. They would say he had robbed a ship or dug up a pirate's hoard. They would have him in the gaol by suppertime, and some lawyer from Chancery would have the pot, and the lot, and his name, and that would be the end of Moses Valverde's son. He had seen what happened in the backcountry to men who could not prove what was theirs.

So he put the lid back on the pot and filled the hole and laid the bricks back in their order, and he went looking for work.

The congregation met in those years in the long room of a house, as it always had, with the Ark against the east wall and the reading desk in the middle and benches on three sides. The shamash was old Jacob Nathan, who had come from Hamburg and had been sweeping that floor since before David was born, and whose knees had given out on him the winter before. David stood in the yard with his hat in his hands and asked whether anybody had need of a man.

Old Nathan looked at the buckskin and the beard. *Are you a Jew?*

Yes.

Can you get up in the dark?

I've done nothing else for twelve years.

So that was the work. Before light every morning he was to go round to the houses and call the men to make the minyan, ten men for morning prayers, and they would not come unless they were called. Then he was to fetch water for washing, trim the candles, sweep, carry the parnas's messages, and do whatever else old Nathan's knees would not let him do. For this the congregation's charity paid him a peck of rice a week and two candles, and gave him the room over the woodshed at the back of the yard, which had a bed in it and a door with no lock.

Very well, said David.

He did it every morning. He went down King Street and along Broad and round by Tradd and Church in the dark, with a lantern, and stood under the windows, and called up to them. He called the way the old shamash had taught him, which was the way it had always been done. *Up, gentlemen. Up, it's nearly light. In a quarter hour you'll be able to tell the blue from the white.* Shutters opened. Men cursed him in Portuguese and English and came down buttoning their coats. By the time the bells of St. Michael's rang the hour he would have his ten.

They called him the woodsman, or *o montero*, the hunter, and that was all the name they needed for him. He told them his name was David, and there were a great many Davids.

III. The Ear

Tradd Street

Mordecai Lobo had been parnas of the congregation more than once. He was past seventy, and his eyes had gone milky, so that he could tell light from dark and not much else. But he had been a merchant for fifty years, and a merchant learns to listen. He knew every man in Charles Town by his voice. He knew them by their coughs, by the way they set down a glass. Men said you could not lie to Mordecai Lobo across a table, because he would hear it, and men who had tried it said the same.

He lay awake before dawn, as old men do. On the third morning that the new man came calling up Tradd Street, he lifted his head off the pillow.

Esther. Who is that?

Esther Carvajal kept his house. She was a widow from Jamaica with a daughter, and she had been in that house eight years, and there was nothing that happened in it that she did not know about before it happened. She was at the window already, building up the fire.

The shamash's new man. The one from the woods.

That, said Mordecai Lobo, *is the voice of a rich man.*

Esther said nothing. But she thought: it doesn't matter what he says, a thing like that ought to be looked into. And when the old man was dressed and gone down, she sent the boy who swept the counting-house round to the back of the yard to have a look.

The boy came back and said: *He's nobody. He has one shirt. He sleeps over the woodshed and the door doesn't lock. They pay him in rice.*

She told the old man. He said nothing. But the next morning, when the call came up the street, he said it again, the same words, *That is the voice of a rich man,* and she sent the boy again, and the boy said again that he was nobody. And the third morning the same.

Esther Carvajal stood at the window that third morning with the poker in her hand and thought it through. The old man has heard the report three times and he doesn't believe it. He has never been wrong about a

voice that I know of. So there's a reason, and somebody ought to find it out, and it might as well be me.

Senhor Lobo, she said. *Give me twenty pounds, currency, and let me have Rebecca for a month, and I'll bring that man's money into this house.*

He laughed, which he did not often do. Then he had the twenty pounds counted out to her.

IV. The Rope Bed

The yard behind the synagogue house

She put Rebecca into an old calico gown with a torn hem and put on another herself, and they went out of the back of the Lobo house with one bundle between them like two women on the road. At the poor rooms behind the synagogue house she knocked and said they were going on to Savannah and wanted a place to lie down for a day or two.

Mrs. Nathan said there were nine of them in two rooms and it was out of the question. *But the woodsman is all alone over the woodshed. Ask him.*

David said no. She asked again, and he said no again. She stood in his doorway and asked a third time and a fourth, and finally said, *One night only, master, just this one night, and we're gone at first light,* and set her bundle down inside the door and would not pick it up again.

In the morning she was still there. When he came back from calling the minyan she said, *Master, before you go to your work, give me what you would spend on your dinner, and I'll cook it for you.*

Never mind that. I cook for myself.

She asked him again, and again, and in the end he gave her his rice and the few coppers he had. She went to the market with them and with some of the twenty pounds besides, and when he came in that evening from carrying water she put in front of him a supper such as he had not eaten since he was fourteen years old. Fish fried in oil and laid in vinegar with onions, the way they made it in Lisbon and London and in Mordecai Lobo's kitchen. Rice cooked in broth with saffron until every grain stood apart. A little pie of chicken and almonds. Sweet oranges.

He ate it all. He sat back against the wall with his eyes half closed, and his hands lay open on his knees.

Master, said Esther, *we're tired. We'll stay a day or two more.*

Very well, he said.

The next night she cooked for him again, and the night after that, and each time when he was full and slow she said, *a few days more,* and he said, *very well,* and so she was living there.

The bed was a rope bed. The ropes ran through holes in the frame, back and forth and across, and the straw tick lay on them. One afternoon while he was out she took a kitchen knife and got down on the floor and cut the cords underneath in several places, close to the frame, where they would not show. When he lay down that night the tick sank in the middle like a hammock.

What's happened to this bed?

Master, I can't keep the boys from next door from coming in and jumping on it.

Woman, this is all on account of you. Before you came I shut the door and went where I liked.

What can I do, my friend? I can't stop them.

Three days she did it, and three nights he lay in the sag and cursed her, and she said the same thing every time. On the fourth day she cut every cord but two. That night when he lay down the whole tick went through to the floor with a crack, and he went with it, folded up in the frame with his knees against his chin.

He climbed out and stood in the dark. *What do I do now? Where am I supposed to sleep?*

Oh, what can I do? Those boys. Well, don't fret, let me think where you can go. And then, as if it had just come to her: *Rebecca, my heart, move over and make room for your brother.*

Rebecca was eighteen. She lay on the pallet by the wall with her face to the wall and did not move, and her mother said it again, and then Rebecca moved over, and said without turning, *Master, there's room here.* And Esther said, *Go on, lie down by your sister.*

Before light Rebecca was crying. She cried without making noise, the way you learn to cry in a house that is not your own. Her mother sat up in the dark.

What is it?

Rebecca told her.

Well, Esther said. *What's done is done. You ought to have a husband, and he ought to have a wife.*

By noon she had two old men from the poor rooms in to witness it, and David said the words to Rebecca over a copper penny with his face burning, and that was a marriage, as far as the poor rooms were concerned. He did not look at Esther. He could not look at Rebecca. He went and called the minyan the next morning as if nothing had happened, because he did not know what else to do.

It was Rebecca who spoke first, a week later, in the dark, in a whisper so her mother would not hear.

What's your name? Your other name.

He lay a long time without answering. Then he told her. He told her about the hole in the wall and the twelve years, and he did not tell her about the pot. She did not say anything. In the morning he waited for Esther to know it, and she did not know it, and the next morning she did not know it either. That was how he found out what kind of wife he had.

V. The Feasts

Purim and Passover, 1772

A few days later Esther sent a note round to Tradd Street. Let the parnas and the elders give out from the reading desk that this year every householder of the congregation is to keep Purim properly, to send portions to his neighbors and give to the poor, and that any householder who does not will pay a fine of forty shillings and have his name read out.

The old man had it given out. Congregations had their rules in those days, and their fines, and nobody thought this one strange except that it was strict.

My son, Esther said to David, *the elders say every householder has to keep Purim this year or pay. What shall we do?*

Mother, I live on a peck of rice. What do you want me to do?

My son, a man with a door of his own can borrow. The elders have to be obeyed, but a debt gets paid somehow or other. Go and find a coin or two somewhere.

He was angry enough to break something. He went out that night in a black temper by the old hole in the wall behind the fig tree, and lifted the third brick and the others in their order, and dug, and took out one coin, a single half-joe, and filled it all in again and came back with the dirt still under his nails and put it in her hand. Esther sent the half-joe round to Tradd Street in a twist of paper, and paid for the Purim portions out of the twenty pounds.

Before Passover she sent another note. The elders gave out that every householder must buy his unleavened bread and his wine from the congregation's baker, at the congregation's price, on pain of the same. And again Esther said what she had said before, word for word, and again David went out in the night to the ruined kitchen, and this time took three, and she sent the three round to Tradd Street.

Mordecai Lobo sat at his table with the four coins in front of him. He could not see them. He picked them up one at a time and turned them in his fingers, and his thumb found on the edge of each of them a small cut, a little nick from a knife, the same on every one.

After a few more days Esther sent a last note. *Now send for him.*

VI. The Drays

The house on Tradd Street

TWO PORTERS AND THE BEADLE CAME FOR HIM WHILE HE WAS sweeping. *Which of you is the woodsman? The parnas wants you.*

David was frightened. He said the parnas did not know him and he had done nothing. He said a good deal more. The porters took him by the arms, and when he would not walk they took him by the arms and legs

and carried him out of the yard like a sack of meal, with the broom still in his hand until he dropped it.

Esther came flying down the stairs. *You dogs. You're not fit to put your hands on my son-in-law.* And to David: *Go along, my son. Don't be afraid. When I see the parnas I'll see to it that these two never carry another load for this congregation as long as they live.* Then she took Rebecca by the hand and ran ahead of them all the way to Tradd Street, and went in by the back door, and took off the torn calico and put on her own good black silk and her garnets, and put Rebecca into the blue silk the old man had given her at New Year, and the two of them stood together at the door of the front room.

The porters brought David in and set him on his feet. He bowed to the old man in the armchair and stood in front of him.

You are the woodsman?

Yes, sir.

Why do you hide your money and go about pretending?

What money, sir? I work for a peck of rice.

Don't do that. Why do you lie to us?

I'm not lying to you, sir. I have nothing.

Mordecai Lobo held out his hand, and on his palm were the four gold pieces. *Then whose are these?*

David knew them. He thought: I'm finished. How did they get here? He looked around the room, and saw the two women in the doorway in their silks with their hands folded, and knew them too, and thought: so that's it. They were his from the beginning. The whole thing was laid like a trap for a fox.

The old man ran his thumb along the edge of the top coin. *Your father put his knife to every coin he owned,* he said, *so he'd know them if they ever came home. I sat across a table from Moses Valverde for thirty years. When I heard you under my window I thought for a moment he'd come back from the dead to call the minyan. You have his voice. Speak, son. Why have you done this?*

I had nobody to stand for me, sir.

You have nobody? You have me.

Then I'd be glad of it, sir, if you'd stand for me.

I will. How much is it?

David told him the sum his father had written on the inside of the lid.

What shall I send for it?

Drays, sir.

The old man sent for drays, and they went down to Elliott Street in a line and backed up to the hole in the wall behind the fig tree, and the porters, the same two, dug out the kitchen hearth under the eyes of the beadle and half the congregation, and found there was not one pot but three, one under the other, as Moses Valverde had never told anybody. They loaded them on the drays in their crust of earth and drove them up to Tradd Street and set them down in the courtyard of the Lobo house, and the beadle opened them, and the gold lay in the April sun in front of everyone.

The driver of the last dray was a gray man in a leather apron, slow now in the shoulders. He had been hired out by the year, ever since the fire, by whatever lawyer had charge of the estate of Moses Valverde, deceased. He stood by his horse's head while they unloaded, and when it was done David went over to him.

Scipio.

Mister David.

You knew me.

First morning you came calling down Church Street. You got your daddy's voice.

Why didn't you say anything?

Scipio looked at him a while. *Wasn't mine to say.*

David stood there with his hands open. Every man in that courtyard knew without being told that the gray man holding the horse was part of what had just come out of the ground, and belonged to the woodsman now, the same as the gold. Neither of them said it. David asked him what he wanted. Scipio told him: his own paper, and his wife's, who belonged to a widow on Queen Street, and a price for her that he named to the shilling, because he had known it for years. David said yes to all of it,

there in the courtyard, in front of the beadle, and had the beadle write it down.

Then Mordecai Lobo had the congregation called together in his courtyard, and stood up among the pots with his hand on the beadle's shoulder.

Is there anybody in this congregation, he said, *who has as much as this?*

Nobody, Senhor.

Then what should be done for him?

Honor him.

So they honored him. They gave him the seat on the east bench beside the parnas's own and put his name among the elders. And in the week after Shavuot, Mordecai Lobo stood under the wedding canopy in the long room as father of the bride and gave Rebecca Carvajal to David Valverde properly, with a contract written out fair by the hazzan and a dowry from his own purse, as if she were his own daughter, and the whole congregation came, and Esther in her garnets wept louder than anybody.

VII. The Hakham

Tradd Street · June

THAT SPRING THERE WAS A GUEST LODGING IN THE LOBO house, a rabbi from Hebron in the Land of Israel. His name was Hakham Eliezer Gabay, and he had been two years on the road, through Leghorn and Amsterdam and London and the islands, collecting for the poor of his city, the way such men had always come round to the scattered congregations, with a letter of credentials and a box. He was a small man with a gray beard who ate very little and said less. He had come up from Jamaica in the spring and would go on to Savannah when the weather turned.

The old man took David to him by the hand, the way you take a boy.

Hakham, look at this one. I never saw such a man. He has a fortune in the ground and it never once went to his head. He put on rags and worked for rice in the yard and swept the floor and called us to prayer every morning in the dark, and nobody knew. I found him out by his voice. I made him own to it, I had it

carried up to my house, I put him on the east bench, I gave him a wife. I never in my life saw anyone so wise.

The hakham looked at David for some time.

Who called the minyan this morning?

I did, Hakham.

And tomorrow?

David had not thought about it. He thought about it now. *I will.*

The hakham nodded, as if that were the whole of it. He said that a man who lives like this lives rightly, rich or poor, and that a man who has nothing and works for his bread lives rightly too. The ones who take what isn't theirs, he said, find no peace in it in this world, and none after. Then he said to Mordecai Lobo, quietly, a verse of Solomon's, the one the old men say when a boy has done his work well.

> *Seest thou a man diligent in his business? he shall stand before kings; he shall not stand before mean men.*
>
> *— Proverbs 22:29*

David heard it, and something in him that had been braced since he was fourteen years old let go. He had stood in front of the old man in the armchair a week before with his heart going like a rabbit's and called it ruin. Standing before him now with the same heart he could see it had been nothing of the kind. The gold had never been the thing. It had been in the ground twelve years and nothing in him had been the worse for it. What he had was the call in the dark, and the ten men coming down the stairs buttoning their coats, and the doing of a thing because it was his to do. He saw it plainly, all at once, and he would never be able to unsee it, and he did not want to.

The hakham went on to Savannah in July with a good deal more in his box for Hebron than he had come with, and no one in the congregation ever learned exactly how much of it had come from whom.

• • •

Old Jacob Nathan's knees did not improve, and the elders said the congregation would hire a new man now, of course, and David Valverde would hear nothing of it.

So for years after that, the men of the congregation woke before light to the same voice under their windows, calling up to them that it was nearly time, that in a quarter of an hour they would be able to tell the blue from the white. Some mornings his wife walked beside him and carried the lantern. On Tradd Street an old man who could no longer see lay awake for it, and when it came he turned over on his pillow, satisfied, and said the same thing every time to the dark room, and nobody ever argued with him.

On Fridays the charity still sent round a peck of rice to the room over the woodshed. David never turned it away. He carried it across the yard to Mrs. Nathan, who had nine in two rooms, and set it down inside her door.

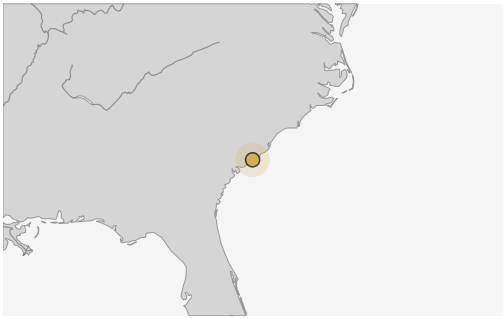
Background

The verse

> *If an earnest person has roused himself, if he is not forgetful, if his deeds are pure, if he acts with consideration, if he restrains himself, and lives according to law,--then his glory will increase.*
>
> Dhammapada 24, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, plague strikes the house of the richest man in Rājagaha. The dying parents tell their son to break through the wall and flee, and tell him where their fortune is buried. He comes back twelve years later, unrecognized, finds the treasure untouched, and leaves it in the ground, afraid he will be taken for a thief. He hires himself out to the servants to wake the workers every morning. King Bimbisāra, who can tell anyone by their voice, hears him and says it is the voice of a rich man. A palace servant woman takes her daughter and moves into his hut, wins him with good cooking, cuts the cords of his bed until it collapses, and marries him to the girl. Then she has the king order compulsory holidays, so the young man has to dig up coins, which she sends to the king. Dragged before the king, he admits his wealth; the king has it carted to the palace, honors him, and gives him his daughter. The

Buddha says that such a man's glory increases. Read the full commentary story, or about King Bimbisāra.



Charles Town, South Carolina

Charles Town, 1760–1772

In January 1760 smallpox swept Charles Town, brought in, it is believed, by soldiers returning from the campaign against the Cherokee in the northwest of the province. According to the South Carolina Historical Society, more than half the town's residents were infected and some nine hundred died, while the physician Alexander Garden inoculated more than two thousand people in two weeks. The Anglo-Cherokee War ended with the Treaty of Charlestown in December 1761, and the deerskin trade that had made merchants like the fictional Moses Valverde rich resumed. The town's new Exchange was built between 1767 and 1771.

Kahal Kadosh Beth Elohim was founded in 1749 as an Orthodox Sephardic congregation, mostly by Jews who had come from London. Its members worshipped in houses converted to synagogues until they dedicated a building on Hasell Street in 1794, and in 1764 they acquired the burial ground on Coming Street. Congregations like it across the Atlantic world were visited by emissaries from the Land of Israel, rabbis who traveled for years collecting for the poor of Jerusalem, Hebron, Safed and Tiberias, and who preached and taught wherever they stopped. One of them, Raphael Haim Isaac Carigal of Hebron, was sent to the West Indies and the North American colonies in the early 1770s. Hakham Gabay, the parnas Mordecai Lobo and the Valverde family are invented.

After the story of Kumbhaghosaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 24). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society Tanakh (1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.3

Little Wayland

> *Not that which goeth into the mouth defileth a man; but that which cometh out of the mouth, this defileth a man.*
> *— Matthew 15:11*

Now this is how I heard it, on Hackberry Street.

I. The Road

Caddo Springs, Alabama · 1938

The Pruett house sat on the only hill in Caddo Springs, three stories of white board and green shutter, and Harlan Pruett kept his daughter in it the way he kept the deeds in his safe. He locked her up, counted on her every night, and brought her out for church.

Eleanor was nineteen that summer. Amos Reed was twenty-four. He drove the Packard, cut the grass, and hauled the ice up from the depot wrapped in croker sacks. Nobody in town would ever be able to say how it started, because nobody in town could imagine that it had, and the two people who knew never told. It went the way water goes through a levee, one grain and then another, and then there was no levee.

They left in October on the night train to Birmingham with forty dollars and a cardboard suitcase. In Birmingham they did not sit together. In Memphis they did not walk together. They did not stop being afraid until somewhere north of Cairo, Illinois, and even then they never stopped all the way.

Detroit took them in the way Detroit took everybody, without asking and without caring. Amos found work at a foundry on the river. Eleanor found a room above a tailor's on Hastings Street where nobody looked twice, because everybody there had a reason not to.

When she was carrying her first, she wanted her mother. She said it every night. A girl wants her mother for that, Amos, it don't matter what she did. So in the eighth month, against everything he knew, Amos bought two tickets south. The baby came in the back of a Trailways bus outside Kankakee with a nurse from Gary holding Eleanor's hand, and they got off at the next town and turned around.

She named him Wayland, because he was born on the way.

Two years later she wanted her mother again, and two years later it happened again, on the shoulder of Highway 51 in Kentucky, in the front seat of a borrowed Ford with the hood up and steam coming off it like a kettle. Having used the name once, she gave it to him too. They called him Little Wayland, then Little Way, and finally, because the world is lazy, just Little.

II. The Carriage House

Caddo Springs · 1952

It was Wayland who asked first. Other boys on Hastings Street had grandmothers who came on Sundays with pound cake. Where were theirs? Eleanor said far. Wayland asked how far. Eleanor said Alabama, and Wayland, who was quick, went to the library and found it on a map, and came home and said that wasn't so far, he'd measured it with a string.

Eleanor wrote her father that winter. He answered in March, two lines in his bank hand. *I will not see you or that man. Send the boys.*

Amos said no. Amos said it for a year. Then the ladle chain at the foundry let go and a pour of iron came down where his feet had been half a second before, and took his left foot anyway, and the money ran out the way it does. In June of 1952 Eleanor pinned paper tags to two jacket lapels and put her sons on the City of New Orleans and did not cry until the train was gone.

Harlan Pruett met them at the Caddo Springs depot after dark with his hat pulled low. He looked at Wayland a long time, because Wayland had his mother's eyes and the town's own color, nearly. He looked at Little a

shorter time, because Little was darker, and had his father's quiet, and looked at the old man the way a dog looks at weather.

The boys did not go in the big house. They went up the outside stairs to the rooms over the carriage house where Hattie Greer, who had cooked for the Pruetts for thirty-one years, was told to tell anybody who asked that they were her sister's boys from up north. Hattie looked at Mr. Pruett when he said it. Then she said yes sir, and took the boys up, and fed them, and never said one word about it to anybody, then or later.

Their grandmother watched them from the upstairs window. She sent down pie. She did not come down.

Their grandfather came down. Sunday nights, after the house was dark, he would climb the carriage house stairs and sit in the one good chair and ask about their sums. Wayland always had his sums. Little never did. The old man would look at Little's tablet, at the numbers that started out right and wandered off somewhere in the middle, and he would say nothing, and set it down very carefully, as if it might break.

III. The Grove

The old Mabry place, on the Tombigbee · 1956

Past the end of the Pruett land, where the road gave up and turned to sand, there was a pecan grove that had belonged to the Mabrys until the Mabrys died out. A man named Sutton lived there now. Some said he had taught chemistry at Tuskegee. Some said he had done eleven years at Kilby. Some said both, and that the order mattered. He was tall and grey at the temples and he moved slowly, as if he had already been everywhere he was going.

Men came out to the grove to hear him, and some of them stayed. A sharecropper from Sumter County. A veteran who did not sleep. A white boy from Mobile with burn scars up both arms. A man who had been the worst drunk in Marengo County and was now nothing at all, which he said was better. They wore plain khaki. They owned what they could carry. Mornings they walked into town with tin pails and stood quiet at back doors, and took what people gave, and said thank you either way.

There were fifty of them, give or take, and the town did not know what to make of them, and so mostly left them alone. That was the closest thing to a miracle anybody in Caddo Springs would admit to.

Wayland was seventeen when he started going out there on Sunday afternoons. He sat at the edge and listened. Brother Sutton did not preach the way the preachers in town preached. He did not raise his voice. He talked about what a man wants and what wanting does to him, and how the wanting was not the man. He talked as if he had looked at the inside of a person the way a doctor looks at a lung.

The fourth Sunday, Wayland asked if he could stay.

Harlan Pruett said a great many things that night that Hattie, listening at the kitchen door, would not repeat. But in the end he signed whatever there was to sign, because Wayland was quick, and had already decided, and the old man knew that look. He had seen it on his daughter.

Wayland was good at it. Of course he was. He learned everything Sutton said, word for word, and could say it back better than most men could say the Lord's Prayer. By nineteen he kept the roll and set the work and decided who walked which road in the mornings. Men twice his age asked him what Brother Sutton had meant.

In the spring of 1958 he walked up the hill and asked his grandfather to let Little come out too.

The old man looked out the window at the carriage house for a long while. *Take him,* he said. *Lord knows I don't know what to do with him.*

IV. The Verse

The grove · spring and summer, 1959

Little was not stupid. He could tell what was wrong with a truck by listening to it idle. He knew every bird on the river by its call and most of them by the sound of their wings. He could walk the grove in the black dark and never touch a tree. But words slid off him like rain off a tin roof. They hit, and they made a sound, and they were gone.

Every man who came to the grove learned one verse first. Brother Sutton gave it to them the first week. Wayland gave it to Little.

Consider the lilies of the field, how they grow;
they toil not, neither do they spin:
And yet I say unto you, That even Solomon in all his glory
was not arrayed like one of these.

— Matthew 6:28–29

Little said it at the well. He said it in the outhouse. He said it walking to town with his tin pail and walking back. He said it in his sleep; men heard him. Every morning he would have the first two lines. By noon the second line would have pushed the first one out, the way a new hen pushes an old one off the roost. By night he would have the lilies of the field and nothing else, standing there with no idea how they grew.

That went on for four months.

On the first Friday in August, Wayland took him out past the last row of trees where the others couldn't hear. He was not cruel about it. That was the worst part. He was patient, the way you are patient with a mule that is not going to pull.

I have watched you since April. You can't hold four lines. There are men in town would give anything for the place you're taking up. Go on back up the hill, Little. Granddaddy will find you something.

The next day Dr. Jervis Coleman came out to the grove in his Buick. He was the only Negro doctor in three counties, and he had set the veteran's arm for nothing and pulled the drunk back from the edge twice, and he wanted to feed the whole fellowship Saturday evening at his house on Hackberry Street.

Wayland had the roll. *Forty-nine,* he said.

Dr. Coleman looked over the grove. *I make it fifty.*

Forty-nine. My brother's going home.

Little heard it from the well. He set the bucket down. He decided that night, lying on his cot listening to the cicadas saw at the dark, that he would leave at first light. Not up the hill. North. He had eleven dollars Hattie had given him over the years, a nickel at a time, and he knew how to find Highway 51, because he had been born on it.

V. The Gate

First light, Saturday

Brother Sutton was sitting on an upturned bucket by the gate, as if he had been there all night. Maybe he had.

Where you headed?

My brother says I'm no good for it.

Your brother didn't bring you in here, Sutton said. *I did. A man doesn't go home because his brother says so. Come here.*

He took a handkerchief out of his shirt pocket. It was white cotton, ironed, still holding the creases from the iron. He shook it out and handed it over.

Sit on that step where the sun's going to hit. Rub this between your hands. And while you rub it, say: taking the dirt out. Just that. Can you hold three words?

Yes sir. I can hold three words.

So he sat. The sun came up over the river the color of a peach, then the color of brass. He rubbed the handkerchief between his hands and said *taking the dirt out, taking the dirt out,* low, under his breath, the way he had said the lily verse, except this time nothing slid off, because there was nothing to slide.

His hands had been washed. He had washed them at the pump. But the sun climbed, and the heat came up out of the ground, and the handkerchief went from white to the color of dishwater to the color of a mule's flank, and it was his hands doing it, his own clean hands.

He stopped rubbing and looked at it.

And he remembered, from nowhere, his father in the yard behind the tailor's on Hastings Street, a Saturday in August, home from the foundry, taking a white handkerchief out of his back pocket and wiping his forehead with it. How it came away dark. How his father stood there in the heat and looked at it for a long time, longer than a man looks at a handkerchief, and then folded it and put it away and never said what he'd been thinking.

Little knew now what he'd been thinking. It went into him the way cold water goes into a dry field, not across the top but down. A thing starts out clean, and it does not stay how it starts. Nothing does. Not the cloth, and not the hands, and not the boy holding them, and not the hill, and not the house on it, and not whatever it was in that house that would not come down the stairs.

He was still sitting there when Brother Sutton came back across the yard and stood over him so his shadow fell across the cloth.

It ain't the cloth, son, Sutton said. *Listen.*

> *Not that which goeth into the mouth defileth a man; but that which cometh out of the mouth, this defileth a man.*
>
> *But those things which proceed out of the mouth come forth from the heart; and they defile the man. For out of the heart proceed evil thoughts, murders, adulteries, fornications, thefts, false witness, blasphemies:*
>
> *These are the things which defile a man: but to eat with unwashed hands defileth not a man.*
>
> *— Matthew 15:11, 18–20*

He said it once.

Little had it. All of it, the way you have your own name. And the lily verse came up behind it like a fish rising, all four lines, in order, and behind that came every word he had heard Brother Sutton say in fifteen months of sitting at the back, words he had not known he'd kept, words that had gone into him and lain down in the dark and waited. They came up now and stood in a row in the morning light, and he could see every one of them.

Sutton put his hand on Little's head for a moment, the way you'd test a melon, and went off to town in his khakis with his tin pail, like any other day.

VI. The Supper

Hackberry Street · Saturday evening

Dr. Coleman had strung bulbs through the chinaberry trees in his yard and set out sawhorse tables with white sheets on them, and his wife and Hattie Greer and four women from Mount Pisgah had been cooking since Thursday. Ham and greens and butter beans and sliced tomatoes and cornbread in iron skillets, and peach cobbler under dish towels against the flies.

When the men were seated, the doctor brought out a basin and a pitcher, as was his custom, to pour water over Brother Sutton's hands before the meal. Sutton put his hand flat over the basin.

Is there anybody left out at the grove?

Wayland answered. He had the roll in his shirt pocket. *No sir. Nobody.*

There's somebody.

Wayland started to say something and didn't. Dr. Coleman looked from one of them to the other and then called for his son Marcus, who was eleven and had a red Schwinn, and told him to ride out to the Mabry place and bring back whoever he found.

Marcus was gone a half hour. He came back slow, walking the bike, and he was the color of ash, and he went straight to his daddy and not to Brother Sutton.

Daddy, it's full.

What's full?

The grove. There's men under every tree. There's men on the porch roof. There's men sitting on the well. I couldn't count them. I said I'm looking for Little Reed, and every one of them said, that's me. All at once. Every one.

The yard went quiet enough to hear the bulbs hum.

Brother Sutton turned his water glass a quarter turn on the sheet. *Go on back,* he said to the boy, kindly. *Whichever one says it first, you take him by the hand. The rest will see themselves out.*

Marcus went back, because the doctor nodded. Afterward he told it all his life, at barbershops and at funerals and, many years later, to a reporter from Birmingham who did not print it. He said he stood at the gate and

said the name, and one man was a little quicker than the others, and Marcus took him by the hand, and when he looked up the grove was just the grove, pecan trees in the last light, empty, the way a room is empty after you wake up.

Little walked into the yard on Hackberry Street holding the boy's hand, and sat at the end of the last table, and ate a plate of butter beans like any man who had been working.

When the cobbler was gone, Dr. Coleman stood and asked Brother Sutton to give thanks for the meal.

Sutton looked down the table. *Little,* he said.

Wayland's face did something then that he would think about for the rest of his life.

Little stood up. He said the lily verse first, all four lines, plain, with the lilies and the toiling and the spinning and Solomon in all his glory each in its place. Then he kept going. He talked for a long time, and nobody shifted on the benches. He said things Brother Sutton had said in the grove in 1957 that Wayland had been there for and had forgotten. He said things about the doctor's hands, and the women's hands, and the hog's life, and the field the greens came out of, and the man who had sharecropped that field, and the man who owned it, and how all of it came down to this one table under these bulbs, and how none of it would stay. He said what defileth a man and what defileth not. He said it the way you would tell somebody the river's rising.

Hattie Greer stood at the kitchen door with a dish towel over her shoulder and cried the whole time, without making a sound, the way she had done everything for thirty-eight years.

VII. The Island

The grove · that night

THE MEN BUILT A FIRE BY THE RIVER AFTER, BECAUSE NOBODY was going to sleep. They kept saying it to each other. Four months he couldn't hold a verse. One breakfast with Brother Sutton and he held all of it.

Sutton came down and sat on a stump and listened to them a while.

He's always been slow, he said. *And I've always been around. That's all it is.*

Somebody asked him what he meant, always, and he told them a story instead, which was his way.

There was a rich man in Mobile, he said, a cotton factor, walking down Dauphin Street with his clerk, and he stepped over a dead rat in the gutter, and he said, half a joke, *A sharp boy could make a living off that.* A shoeshine boy on the corner heard it and did not take it for a joke. He picked up the rat by the tail and sold it to a woman down by the wharf who had a cat to feed, for one penny. With the penny he bought a jar of cane syrup, and he carried a bucket of well water and the syrup down to where the flower women came in off the boats in the heat, and gave them sweet water for nothing, and they gave him flowers. He sold the flowers. With the flower money he bought a hatchet, and cut the deadfall after a storm, and sold the firewood. He gave the grass cutters at the racetrack a drink every morning, and they owed him, and when a horse barge came in, he had bought up every bale of grass in Mobile with a promise and a handshake. Out of a rat. By the end, he was a man of some account, and he walked into the cotton factor's office and put half of it on the desk and said, *You told me how.* And the cotton factor looked at that boy a long time, and at the money, and at the rat he must have remembered, and he stood up from his desk and gave him his daughter's hand.

Nobody around the fire said anything to that. A cotton factor on Dauphin Street. A shoeshine boy. The white boy from Mobile with the burned arms looked into the coals like he was trying to picture the office. Wayland looked at Little, and Little was looking at the river, and both of them were thinking about a tailor's shop on Hastings Street, and a woman who had wanted her mother twice and never once got there.

That happen? the veteran said finally.

It's a story, Sutton said. *It's older than Mobile. It's just waiting on Mobile to catch up.*

For who hath despised the day of small things? Sutton said. *Zechariah. A small fire, you blow on it right, it'll come up.*

Who was the boy? the veteran asked.

Sutton poked the fire with a stick. *Same boy as always.*

• • •

Later, when the fire was mostly coals, Wayland found his brother down at the water. The Tombigbee was running high from rain upriver, brown and fast, carrying whole trees past them in the dark.

Wayland stood there and tried to start four or five sentences. Little let him try. Then he said, *You don't owe me nothing, Way. You ain't the one kept me out. I was.*

They stood a while. A heron went over, low, and Little named it without looking up.

Brother Sutton's voice came down from the fire, talking to nobody in particular, or to the river.

> *Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock: And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.*
>
> *— Matthew 7:24–25*

• • •

The next Sunday, Little walked up the hill. Not to the carriage house stairs. Up the front walk, between the boxwoods, onto the porch, to the front door with the brass knocker that he had never once in seven years touched.

Harlan Pruett opened it himself. Behind him on the stairs, with one hand on the rail, was a small grey woman Little had only ever seen through glass.

Nobody said anything for a long time. The cicadas went on in the pecans. Somewhere down in the town a screen door slapped.

I came to say the blessing, Little said. *If you'll have it.*

His grandfather looked at him the way he used to look at the tablet with the wandering sums. Then he stepped back from the door, and held it.

In Little's shirt pocket was a handkerchief, folded square, grey as a mule's flank. He had not washed it. He did not mean to.

Background

The verse

> *By rousing himself, by earnestness, by restraint and control, the wise man may make for himself an island which no flood can overwhelm.*
>
> Dhammapada 25, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary tells this verse's story through Culla Panthaka, the slowest of the Buddha's disciples, who could not learn four lines in four months, was turned out by his own brother, and woke to the whole teaching while rubbing a clean cloth in the sun. Read the full commentary story, or about Culla Panthaka in the wider tradition.

Caddo Springs, Alabama

Alabama, 1959

Alabama's 1901 constitution forbade the legislature from ever authorizing a marriage between a white person and a Black person, and state law made such a marriage a crime. A couple like Eleanor and Amos had no lawful way to exist in the state; leaving was the only option, and leaving was dangerous. The U.S. Supreme Court struck down these laws nationwide in *Loving v. Virginia* in 1967, but the dead language stayed in Alabama's constitution until voters removed it in 2000, with about 40 percent voting to keep it. More at anti-miscegenation laws in the United States.

The road north the couple took was the road of the Great Migration, which carried some six million Black Southerners to Northern and Western cities between 1910 and 1970. In Detroit, Hastings Street ran through Black Bottom and Paradise Valley, the center of Black business and music in the city, until urban renewal and the I-375 freeway cleared it in the late 1950s and early 1960s. The grove sits on the Tombigbee, which runs south through Alabama's western Black Belt.

After the story of Culla Panthaka and his brother from the commentary on Dhammapada verse 25. The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.4

Folding Chairs

"Quick! quick! so that the time may not be lost
By little love!"
— Dante, Purgatorio XVIII, 103–104

Azoy hob ikh gehert, in the card room of the Coral Arms.

I. The Chair

Fort Lauderdale, Florida · March 1985

EVERY MORNING AT A QUARTER TO SIX BELLA KAGAN TOOK THE folding chair out of the hall closet of the Coral Arms, the aluminum one with the green and white webbing, and carried it down the stairs and across A1A and over the soft sand to the place where the sand turned hard. Then she went back for the Maestro.

He was eighty-seven years old and he could still walk, if it was slow and somebody had his elbow. He wore a linen cap and a white shirt buttoned to the collar and the same grey trousers every day of the year, and he carried a cane he mostly did not lean on. His eyes had gone in the last few years. He could see light and dark and the shape of a person against a window, and that was about all. When they reached the chair he felt for its arms, turned himself around and sat, and Bella put the cane across his knees and went back up to make coffee. He stayed there an hour. He did not read, because he couldn't, and he did not sleep, and he did not pray, because he had not prayed since 1911. He listened.

The Coral Arms was six stories of pink stucco built in 1956, a block north of Las Olas, across the road from the beach. In 1971 a group of retired garment workers from the Bronx and Brooklyn had bought it together as a co-op, apartment by apartment, with their savings and their

small union pensions, and by now forty-eight of its fifty units belonged to people who had spent their working lives at sewing machines and cutting tables and pressing irons on Seventh Avenue. About half of them were Jews from Local 22, the dressmakers, and about half were Italians from Local 89, which had been the Italian dressmakers' local and was named for the year of the French Revolution. They had fought each other on the shop floor over piece rates and seating and who got the window, and they had stood on the same picket lines in the same snow, and now they played pinochle together in the card room on the ground floor and argued about the Mets.

Settimio Barsanti had come from Carrara in 1921, a marble cutter's son, and pressed dresses on West Thirty-Fifth Street for nine years, and then the union had found out he could teach. For thirty years after that he taught for the educational department of Local 89. He taught English to girls from Bari and Palermo who had left school at ten. He taught them how to read a contract. On Thursday nights, for whoever wanted to come, he taught Dante, the whole Commedia, a canto a week, and when he got to the end of Paradiso he started over at the dark wood. Half the Italian women in the Coral Arms had sat in those Thursday classes as girls. So had a few of the Jewish ones, because in 1934 nobody cared whose local you were in if the room was warm.

He still did Thursdays, in the card room, with the tables pushed back. He had the whole thing by heart. He sat with his hands folded on the cane and said it in Italian and then in English, in the old translation by Longfellow that he said was too polite but honest, and the men who had come only for the coffee and cake fell asleep, and the women did not.

Bella had not been one of his girls. She was a finisher, Local 22, forty-one years of hand-sewing hems and buttons and hooks and eyes, and she had come to the Thursdays only after her husband Morris died, because the apartment was too quiet at night. Now she was the one who carried the chair. Nobody had decided it. It had simply become hers, the way the job of threading needles had become hers, for the women in the building whose eyes were going. They brought her their needles in the card room, a little packet of them, and their spools, and she threaded them one after

another without looking much, the way she had done it ten thousand times on the line, and stuck them back in the paper.

How do you do that without looking, Carmela Russo asked her once.

I'm looking, said Bella. *Just not with the eyes so much.*

The Maestro, who had been sitting nearby, laughed out loud, which he did not do often.

In the shop, he said, *attention was the only thing they couldn't take from us. They took the hours. They took the wages. They took the fingers, sometimes, when a girl stopped attending to the needle. But the attention was ours. It was the whole capital we had.*

It was the longest speech anybody had heard from him outside of Thursday, and Carmela wrote it down on the back of a pinochle score.

II. The Strip

A1A, between Las Olas and Sunrise

They had known about the college students when they bought the building. Everybody in Fort Lauderdale knew. Since before the war the colleges had sent their swimmers down at Christmas, and after the movie with Connie Francis in 1960 the rest of the students came after the swimmers, every year a few more, every spring, for the weeks around Easter. In the first years at the Coral Arms the residents had thought it was charming. The boys were polite. The girls wore white bathing caps. Mrs. Fishbein from 4C fed them rugelach on the steps.

By 1985 there were three hundred and fifty thousand of them in a season, and the city could not count them except by the garbage.

They came in March in cars with plates from Ohio and Michigan and New York and Ontario, eight to a car, and they drove up and down A1A from Las Olas to Sunrise and back again, bumper to bumper, all day and half the night, with their arms out the windows and the radios loud. They slept eight to a motel room and in their cars and on the beach. In Florida that spring you could drink at nineteen, and the bars along the Strip opened their sides to the sidewalk and sold beer by the pitcher before noon. There were wet T-shirt contests and belly-flop contests and con-

tests in which girls ate bananas on a stage while boys shouted at them. The boys painted the letters of their fraternities on their chests in shoe polish and their faces in white zinc, and everybody, boys and girls both, oiled themselves all over with coconut oil until the whole beach smelled of it, a sweet smell, like a cake left too long in the oven, and under it, by afternoon, the other smell, of beer turning in the sun and of what the hedges along the Coral Arms had been used for in the night.

The noise did not stop. It went down a little between four and six in the morning, and then the trash trucks came.

They shouted at everybody. They shouted up at the balconies of the Coral Arms, at the old women hanging out towels, things that Bella had not heard said in English since a foreman named Kaplowitz in 1937, and even Kaplowitz had lowered his voice. They shouted at the Haitian men who raked the beach and at the police and at the girls in their own cars. They shouted at a priest in his collar. They shouted at each other, the worst things, and laughed, and threw their arms around each other's necks.

Angelo Esposito in 2B found two boys asleep in the doorway of the building one morning, with a cooler, and a girl with them, and when he asked them to go they told him what he could do, in detail, and did not go. So he went upstairs and came down with a five-dollar bill, and they took it and went. After that he kept a stack of ones in a coffee can by his door. A dollar to move a car out of the residents' lot. Two dollars to stop sitting on the wall. Five to take a cooler off the front steps. He was not the only one. By the middle of March half the building was paying the students to go away, and the students had worked it out, and came back.

It's like the Black Hand, said Carmela. *Except they're blond.*

On a Tuesday morning in the second week of March, Bella came back across A1A with the coffee in a thermos and found three boys standing over the Maestro's chair.

They had not been to bed. One of them had a Greek letter on his chest in shoe polish, run with sweat, and white zinc on his nose and his ears, and a beer can in each hand. Another one had the Maestro's linen cap on. They were talking to him the way you would talk to a dog that had gotten

onto the beach. What are you doing, Pop. Hey, Gandhi. Are you dead. One of them asked him if he could still, and used a word. The Maestro sat with his hands folded on the cane, looking out at the ocean he could not see, and did not answer, and this made them laugh more. The boy with the letter on his chest poured beer slowly into the sand beside the chair, near the Maestro's shoe, and said it was holy water.

Bella said, *Give him his hat.*

They looked at her, and then they told her what she looked like, and what she could do, and how old she was, as if she might not know. But they gave the hat back. The one wearing it put it on the Maestro's head himself, crooked, and patted it, and they went off up the beach toward the Elbo Room with their arms around each other, singing.

Bella straightened the cap. Her hands were shaking. The Maestro's were not.

They're children, he said.

They're animals.

No. Animals would have more sense. And he held out his hand for the coffee.

III. The Week

The card room, Coral Arms

The board met that Thursday night instead of Dante. Sol Pomerantz, who had been a cutter in Local 10 and was the president of the co-op, stood at the end of the pinochle table with a copy of the Sun-Sentinel and read out of it. The big schools from the Midwest had their break the next week, all at once. The paper said the next week would be the worst week of the season. Sol said he had talked to a man at the Chamber of Commerce and the man had said the same, and had also said, in a way Sol did not care for, that the students brought a great deal of money into the city.

So what do we do? said Mrs. Fishbein.

We do what we did in the shop when the boss went crazy, said Carmela. *We keep our heads down until he gets tired.*

They decided it among themselves in twenty minutes, which for that room was a record. For seven days nobody would go out who did not have to. They would bring in groceries on the Sunday and not go out again until the Sunday after. Anybody who had a doctor's appointment would take a taxi from the back door on the side street. They would keep the blinds down on the ocean side. And the Maestro, they all agreed, would not go to the beach. Not at six in the morning, not at any hour. Not for seven days.

Who's going to tell him? said Sol, and they all looked at Bella.

She went up to the second floor and knocked. He was sitting by the window in the dark, as he often did, because a lamp made no difference to him and he said it was a waste of Florida Power and Light. She explained. She told him about the paper and the Midwestern schools and the vote, and that they would bring him his meals, three a day, they had made a list already, he didn't have to do a thing.

She expected an argument. He had never missed a morning in fourteen years, not for hurricanes, not for the week his wife was dying, when he had gone at six and come back at seven and sat with her all the rest of the day.

Va bene, he said. *Seven days is nothing. And you, you'll stay in also?*

All of us.

Good. Then nobody gets lost.

IV. Seven Days

Saturday to Saturday

They carried his meals up the stairs on trays covered with dish towels, as they had agreed. On Sunday it was Bella's brisket. On Monday it was Carmela's escarole and beans, and Mrs. Fishbein's chicken soup at night, because Mrs. Fishbein believed that the Maestro, being thin, was always one day from death. On Tuesday Angelo Esposito's wife Philomena sent up eggplant, and Sol, who could not cook, sent up a box of rugelach from the bakery on Sunrise and a note in his cutter's square

CAPITALS THAT SAID STAY INSIDE. THE MAESTRO ATE A LITTLE of everything, and sent every plate back washed.

Outside it was as the paper had said. The cars on A1A did not move at all for whole afternoons, and the students stood up through the sunroofs and on the hoods and shouted from car to car. Someone set up a loudspeaker on a hotel balcony down the block and played the same song by Bruce Springsteen over and over until a policeman went up and took it away, and then someone played it from another balcony. A police helicopter went up and down the beach. On Monday night a boy climbed the Coral Arms' palm tree and could not get down, and the fire department came. On Tuesday the girls on the balcony of the motel next door hung a bedsheet over the rail with words painted on it in red, and the words were about the old people in the Coral Arms, and the Coral Arms read them through the slats of the blinds and did not discuss them.

Bella stayed in. She played solitaire and listened to the radio and did not sleep well. The coconut oil came in through the closed windows, through the air conditioning, through the walls. She found herself remembering her father, who had been a shames in a shul on Stone Avenue in Brownsville, and who used to sit at the kitchen table on summer nights, when the boys from the corner were making noise under the windows, and say the verses from Koheles to himself in Hebrew, under his breath, the way another man might count to ten. When she was small she had asked what it meant and he had told her in Yiddish, and when she was older she had looked it up in English in the Jewish Publication Society Bible her brother brought home from school.

> *The heart of the wise is in the house of mourning; but the heart of fools is in the house of mirth. It is better to hear the rebuke of the wise, than for a man to hear the song of fools. For as the crackling of thorns under a pot, so is the laughter of the fool; this also is vanity.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 7:4–6*

The crackling of thorns. She had never seen a thorn burn, and she lay awake on the Wednesday night and listened to the laughter come up

from the Strip, and thought that her father had been right about the sound of it. It caught fast, and it was loud, and there was nothing in it to cook a pot.

On Thursday afternoon her grandson came.

She had known he might. Her daughter had written in February that Jason and two boys from his dormitory at the state college in Oneonta were driving down for the break, and that he would surely come by to see his grandmother, and Bella had written back to say she would make a kugel. She heard the buzzer and saw him through the glass of the front door, and she went down herself and let him in. He was nineteen, tall, burned red across the nose and shoulders, in cut-off jeans and nothing else, and he shone with the oil. Two other boys came in behind him and stood in the lobby looking at the pictures of the board presidents on the wall, and one of them laughed at Sol Pomerantz's picture and said something about it, and it was not a kind thing.

Grandma, said Jason, and hugged her, and she smelled the beer. He wanted to know if they could use her shower. Their motel's water was out. And could they leave a cooler in her refrigerator, because the motel's ice machine was broken, and could they maybe, just for a night or two, sleep on her floor, because the motel was a joke. He told her what the motel was like, and how much they had paid, and what the girls next door had done, and he did not seem to notice what he was saying or who he was saying it to. One of his friends said something to the other about the old ladies in the lobby, low, but not low enough. Jason laughed.

Grandma, don't be so, he said, when he saw her face, and then he said a word that she had heard on the beach on Tuesday morning, said lightly, said fondly, the way you might tell your grandmother she had a smudge on her cheek.

She stood in the lobby of the Coral Arms in her housedress. She thought of Morris, who had carried this boy on his shoulders down the boardwalk at Brighton Beach. She thought of the coffee can by Angelo Esposito's door.

She went upstairs and came back down with her purse, and took out a twenty-dollar bill and two fives, and gave the twenty to Jason and a five each to his friends.

For a better motel, she said. *Go.*

He looked at the money and then at her, and for a moment she thought he understood. Then he grinned and kissed her on the cheek and said, *Grandma, you're the best,* and they went out with their cooler into the noise, and the door swung shut on its slow closer, and the lobby smelled of coconut for an hour.

That night it was Bella's turn to take up the Maestro's dinner. She brought him the kugel. He was sitting at the window in the dark with the blinds open an inch, listening.

Something happened, he said, before she had put the tray down.

She told him. She had not meant to cry and did not, quite. He listened to all of it with his head a little on one side, the way he listened to the ocean, and when she was finished he did not tell her what it meant. He asked whether the kugel had raisins in it. She said it did. He said good, and ate it all.

On Friday night there were sirens at two in the morning and the next day the building heard that a boy from Indiana had fallen from a fourth-floor balcony at a hotel on the next block, trying to step across to the balcony beside it. He had lived. People said he had landed in a hedge. Nobody in the Coral Arms said anything about it at all, not even Carmela, and on Saturday the rain came in off the ocean in the afternoon and drove everyone off the beach, and in the evening, when it stopped, the cars began to leave. Bella heard them going all night, north on A1A toward the interstate, honking, the radios fading off one after another toward Ohio.

V. The Eighth Day

Sunday morning

At half past five on Sunday Bella woke and did not know why, and then she knew. It was quiet.

She dressed. She did not put on a housedress. She put on her good navy blue with the white collar that she wore to Morris's grave, and her straw hat, and went down. Carmela was already in the lobby in black with a cake box tied with string. Sol was there in pressed slacks and a jacket, holding four folding chairs under each arm like a cutter carries bolts. Angelo and Philomena came down the stairs with a coffee urn between them from the card room, the big one they used for funerals. Mrs. Fishbein had a tablecloth. They kept coming down, out of the elevator and down the stairs, in their good clothes, as if somebody had sent out invitations, though nobody had. Thirty, forty of them. Women in hats. Men who had not worn ties since the last bar mitzvah. Every one of them carrying a chair.

Bella went up for the Maestro. He was waiting, dressed, with his cap on and his cane across his knees.

I heard, he said. *They're gone.*

They crossed A1A all together, slowly, at the pace of the slowest, which was his. There were no cars. The road was strewn with cans and paper cups and a single pink sandal and a great many cigarette butts, and the city's sweeper truck was working its way up from Las Olas with its brushes turning. The beach was worse. Cans lay half buried all the way down to the water, and someone had built a car out of sand in the night with a real steering wheel stuck in it, and the gulls were going over the trash in rows, as methodical as finishers. They carried the chairs down through it. At the hard sand by the tide line Bella set the green and white chair where it always went, and the others opened theirs in a half circle around it, and spread Mrs. Fishbein's tablecloth on the sand for the cake and the mandelbrot and the coffee, and the Maestro sat down in the middle, and the sun came up out of the Atlantic.

They told him about the week. Everybody had a piece of it. Sol told him about the bedsheet on the balcony and what was painted on it, which nobody had told him before. Angelo told him how much money had gone out of the coffee can; he had written it down; it was sixty-four dollars. Mrs. Fishbein said she had not slept. Carmela said her ears had nearly burst. They told him nobody out there had respected anybody, not

the police, not the priest, not their own mothers, not themselves. They told him it was a mercy he had not been out in it. Bella did not tell about Jason. She did not have to; she saw that Carmela knew, and that probably the whole building knew, and that they were not going to say anything, and she loved them for it.

The Maestro listened to all of it with his hands folded on the cane. When they were done, he was quiet for a while. A wave came up the sand, thin as a sheet of paper, and went back.

Così fanno, he said. *That's how they do. It's what people do when they think there's plenty of time. They have their fathers' money, and they have their health, and they think they have time, all the time in the world, and so they throw it in the street like the cans.* He turned his face toward the sound of the sweeper truck on A1A. *I did it too, in Carrara. Not so loud.*

And us? said Sol.

Us, we have no money and we know we have no time. So we keep the other thing. He was quiet a moment. *Do you know what I did all week, in the dark, in my chair? I listened. The same as here. Through the window you can hear the ocean under the radios, if you attend to it. Under the Springsteen. Under the helicopter. It never stopped once. All week, under everything. It was there the whole time.*

Then he said it in Italian, for the ones who had been his girls, and then in English, for the rest, in the voice he used on Thursdays. He said it was from the fourth terrace of the mountain of Purgatory, where the souls who had been slothful in life, who had loved too little and too slowly, ran day and night around the mountain and would not stop, and called out to each other as they ran.

> *"Quick! quick! so that the time may not be lost*
> *By little love!" forthwith the others cried,*
> *"For ardour in well-doing freshens grace!"*
>
> *— Dante, Purgatorio XVIII, 103–105*

They were the lazy ones once, he said. *Now they are the ones who run. That is what attention is. It's the only treasure that you keep by spending it.*

Then he said one more, which some of the women in the circle had heard him say in a cold classroom on West Thirty-Fifth Street fifty years before, to girls who had been sewing since they were twelve, and which a few of them now said along with him, in Italian, under their breath. He said Ulysses said it to his sailors, and that Ulysses was a liar and in Hell and it was true anyway.

> *Consider ye the seed from which ye sprang;*
> *Ye were not made to live like unto brutes,*
> *But for pursuit of virtue and of knowledge.*
>
> *— Dante, Inferno XXVI, 118–120*

Then he stopped talking and turned his face to the water, and so did they.

The people who were in that half circle on the sand told it afterward the same way, and they were not people who agreed about anything. They said that for a while, it might have been the length of a canto, they heard the ocean the way he must have been hearing it every morning for fourteen years. Each wave by itself. The long breath of it drawing back over the shells, and the small sounds inside the large sound, the hiss and the tick and the turning-over, and a gull, and somebody's coffee cup set down on the tablecloth, and their own breathing, and the Maestro's. Sol Pomerantz, who had been deaf in his left ear since a press blew a gasket in 1948, said he heard it in both ears. Mrs. Fishbein said she was not afraid of anything at all, for the first time since she was a girl, and that it lasted the whole day. Carmela said nothing about it for a year, and then one Thursday told Bella she had felt as if she had been threading a needle her whole life without looking and had just, that morning, looked.

Then the sweeper truck came level with them on A1A, and the spell, if it was one, went on anyway, quieter, and they ate the cake.

VI. The Tracks

The Coral Arms · 1985–1986

That year the mayor went on morning television and told the students of America that they were not welcome in Fort Lauderdale anymore, and the city commission banned open containers on the beach side of A1A and overnight parking on the beach. The police made more than two thousand arrests enforcing it. The spring after that there were fewer students, and fewer the year after, and within a few years they had mostly gone on to Daytona and Panama City and Mexico, where the drinking age was lower. The bar owners on the Strip complained to the paper. The Coral Arms did not.

Jason telephoned in May. He said he was sorry about the money. He said he was going to pay it back, and Bella said to keep it and buy a book, and he laughed and said, okay, Grandma, what book, and she told him Dante, the Longfellow, and to read the part about the mountain. She did not know if he did. He did send her a postcard of the Oneonta bus station, which was a joke, and she put it on the refrigerator.

The Maestro died in February, in his chair by the window, in the dark, at eighty-eight. He had told Carmela where his papers were and what he wanted, which was nothing, no service, no priest, and his ashes in the ocean, which Angelo Esposito saw to from a rented boat, three miles out, having left the marina at six o'clock in the morning with eleven old men and women in good clothes aboard, all of them seasick. Thursday nights went on in the card room. Carmela took the Inferno, and Sol, who it turned out had been listening all along, took the Purgatorio. Nobody would take the Paradiso, and they read it aloud by turns.

Bella went on carrying the chair. Every morning at a quarter to six she took it out of the hall closet and carried it down the stairs and across A1A and set it on the hard sand where the soft sand ended, and sat in it herself, in her housedress, with her hands folded, and listened. When she got up an hour later and folded the chair and carried it back, the two aluminum legs at the front left two short tracks in the wet sand, side by side,

and she would stop at the top of the beach and turn around and watch the water come up and fill them, and smooth them over, and go back.

Background

The verses

> *Fools follow after vanity, men of evil wisdom. The wise man keeps earnestness as his best jewel.*
>
> Dhammapada 26, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Follow not after vanity, nor after the enjoyment of love and lust! He who is earnest and meditative, obtains ample joy.*
>
> Dhammapada 27, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the city of Sāvatthī keeps a seven-day Fools' Festival, when revelers smear themselves with ash and cow-dung and stand in doorways shouting coarse abuse at everyone, kin, friends and monks alike, until people pay them a coin to go away. The Buddha's lay followers ask him to stay at the monastery for the week, send food out to the monks, and do not leave their own houses. On the eighth day they bring him into the city with great offerings and tell him how their ears nearly burst. He answers that fools behave this way, and that the wise guard heedfulness (*appamāda*, attention, earnestness) as their greatest treasure, and many who hear him enter the stream. Read the full commentary story.

Fort Lauderdale, Florida

Fort Lauderdale, 1985

Fort Lauderdale's spring break began when the Colgate University swim team came to train there over Christmas in 1934. The 1960 novel and film Where the Boys Are, which featured the Elbo Room on the corner of Las Olas and the beach, brought the

crowds, and by the early 1980s the city drew 250,000 to 350,000 students a season. Florida's drinking age was 19 until the federal National Minimum Drinking Age Act pushed it to 21. In 1985 Mayor Robert Dressler said on *Good Morning America* that students were no longer welcome; the city banned open containers on the beach side of A1A and overnight beach parking, and enforcement brought more than 2,500 arrests. By 1989 about 20,000 students came.

Many of the retirees along the Florida coast had spent their working lives in New York's garment trade and in the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union, which ran classes, a press and a Pocono resort, Unity House, for its members. Many of its Jewish dressmakers belonged to Local 22; its Italian dressmakers formed Local 89 in 1919, numbered for the year of the French Revolution and led for decades by the anti-fascist Luigi Antonini. The Maestro's Dante is the Longfellow translation of 1867; the running souls of the slothful are on the fourth terrace of the Purgatorio, canto XVIII.

After the story of the Fools' Festival from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 26 and 27). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society Tanakh (1917) and Dante's *Divine Comedy* in Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's translation (1867). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.5

The Counting Tower

Go, set a watchman; let him declare what he seeth.
— Isaiah 21:6

The way I heard it, on the Wood River.

I. Ten Minutes

The outlet of Lake Aleknagik, Bristol Bay, Alaska · July 1961

The tower stood on the right bank where the lake let go into the Wood River. It was twenty feet of pipe scaffold guyed with cable to four spruce stumps, with a plank floor on top, a rail around the floor, and a canvas fly for the rain. Another like it stood on the far bank. The men from the university in Seattle had put up the first towers some years back, and now the state had them. Alaska had been a state for two years and had managed its own fish for one, and the new Department of Fish and Game wanted to know how many red salmon got past the nets in the bay and up into the lakes to spawn. Nobody had ever known that. The canneries knew to the case what they packed. What went by them, up the rivers, to make the fish of four and five years on, had been anybody's guess for seventy years.

The way to know it was a man on a tower. The reds came up out of the bay and they did not use the middle of the river. They kept to the banks, in water a man could wade, in a band four and six and ten fish wide, one band to each side, steady as people going into church. Pale panels had been pinned to the gravel below each tower so the dark backs would show crossing them. A man stood at the rail in Polaroid glasses with a hand counter, the kind with a thumb lever that the cannery tallymen used, and for ten minutes out of each hour he pressed the lever once for

every fish that crossed the panel going up. If one dropped back down he took one off. Then he wrote the number on the sheet and multiplied it by six, and that was the hour. Twenty-four hours were the day. The days added up to the escapement, and by the escapement the men in Dillingham decided whether the boats in the bay could fish on Monday.

Ten minutes in the hour was all of it. The biologist who drove up the lake road in a jeep to set the camp had explained why. A man could not count all day. His eyes went first and then his mind, and he began seeing fish in the riffle that were not there. So you took a piece of each hour and trusted it to stand for the rest. It had been tried against a weir, he said, with every fish put through a gate, and it came out within a few in a hundred.

There were two counters at the right-bank tower that summer. One was a boy named Dale Rasmussen, who had finished two years of fisheries at the university and had never been north of Bellingham. The other was Evon Nicolai, who was fifty-three and lived on the north shore of the lake. The biologist had asked in the village who could be trusted to stay awake, and three different people had given him the same name.

Evon was a helper in the Moravian church. The Moravian people on the lake had come over from Togiak and the Kuskokwim side, most of them, and built their chapel on the north shore a few years before, and a helper was what they called a man who was not a minister and did a minister's work when no minister was near, which was nearly always. He had fished the bay for thirty years in the company sailboats, the double-enders, because until 1951 the law allowed no engine in a Bristol Bay fishing boat, and he had been good at it. His wife Matrona died in 1954. They had no children living. After she died he gave his nets and his share in a boat to her nephew and kept a cabin with a stove, a kettle, a Bible, and a cot.

What he did after that was go around. Every morning he walked the houses of the north shore and then took a skiff across to the south. He read the day's text out of the Moravian text book wherever somebody wanted it read. He prayed with the sick and split wood for the old. Around the middle of the morning, in whatever house he happened to be

in, somebody put food in front of him, and he ate that. It might be a salmon head boiled that hour or a strip of last year's dried fish, hard as a shingle. It might be pilot bread and tea. He ate what there was and said it was good, and he did not carry any of it away, and he did not sit down in the same house twice in one week. The whole lake fed him and no one house felt it.

He took the night shift on the tower, six in the evening until six in the morning. The check the state sent him he signed over to the chapel for stove oil. At six he climbed down, made his round, ate where he was fed, and slept.

II. The Small Book

Kanakanak · 1919

He had learned to count at Kanakanak.

The sickness came into Bristol Bay in the spring of 1919, about the time the ice went out. It was the same sickness that had filled the cities the autumn before, and the country had been shut against it all winter, with no travel between the villages and no church, and it came anyway. It did a strange thing. It left the children and the very old and took the grown men and women. Evon was eleven, in a village on the Nushagak shore. His father died on a Tuesday and his mother on the Thursday, and his mother's sister and her husband in the next house, and his grandfather. By the end of that week there was no grown person in the village on his feet.

He stayed four days in the house with his sister Akilina, who was three. The dogs had not been fed. They broke their chains and went in and out of the houses, and he sat in the doorway with his father's fish pew across his knees, the pole with the one steel tine, and kept them out of his. He could hear them in the other houses. He was eleven and he tried to work out how many people there had been in the village on the Sunday and how many there were now, and he did not have the figures to do it with. He could count to ten in Yup'ik and to ten in Russian, from church, and it was not enough.

The cannery ships came up from the south in May, as they did every year, and found the bay like that. Men from the cannery came along the shore in a boat with rags tied over their faces and carried the children out. All that summer the bunkhouses were full of children. In the fall, when the canneries closed, the children were sent to the government hospital at Kanakanak, near Dillingham, where the doctor took in every one. There were so many that an orphanage grew up beside the hospital to hold them.

There was a young woman at the hospital named Anuska who did the washing. She was twenty-two. She had had the sickness and lived. When she was small she had gone to the Moravians' mission school at Carmel, across the bay, until it closed, and she could read and write English, which few could. When the children came off the boat she washed each one in a tub by the laundry stove and cut their hair for the lice. Then she sat the child on a box and opened a cannery tally book with a red spine and wrote down what the child could tell her. The name. The mother's name and the father's. The village. The little ones did not know, and she wrote what the bigger ones said about them.

Evon told her his name and his sister's, and his mother's and father's.

How many died at our place? he asked her.

I don't know.

Who knows it?

Nobody wrote it, she said. *The men who buried them didn't have time to write.*

He thought about that through the whole winter. Akilina died before Christmas, of a cough, and Anuska wrote that in the book too, on the same line as her name, and he watched her write it.

In the orphanage school he learned figures faster than any child they had. He counted the beds in the long room and the windows and the nails in the floorboards by his cot. Counting was how he got to sleep. When he was grown and fishing, the canneries still paid by the fish, and a tallyman stood on the scow and counted as you pitched your catch up to him one at a time on the pew. Evon always had his own number before

the tallyman said it, and in thirty years the tallyman's was never the higher of the two.

III. All of It

The tower · the second week of July

The run built through the first days of July. At the start he pressed the lever thirty and forty times in his ten minutes. By the sixth he was counting by tens, a press for every ten backs, and the band below him never broke.

The fifty minutes began to trouble him then. He did his ten and wrote his number, and the fish kept going by. They went by all the rest of the hour with nobody's thumb on them. The state was content with that. Evon had never in his life let a fish go past him untallied, and on the night of the eighth, when his ten minutes were up, his thumb kept on.

He was honest about it. He wrote the ten-minute number on the state's sheet, where it belonged. The other number, the whole hour's, he wrote in a school composition book he had bought at the store for fifteen cents. Dale came up the ladder at six that morning and found him at the rail where he had left him at six the night before. He had not sat down.

After that he came at noon as well. He would finish his round, eat in whatever house it was, and come back and climb the tower in the hours that were his to sleep in. He sat on an upturned lard bucket behind Dale with the composition book on his knee. There were things Dale's ten minutes did not reach, and he began on those.

There was the other bank, where two men he had never met counted a band of fish he could not see. There were the fish already in the lake, and the ones gone on up the Agulowak into the lake above. There were the eggs. The biologist had told them a hen carried three thousand and more, and that out of the three thousand perhaps two fish came back, and Evon wanted to know where the others went and at what hour. He thought of the little ones going down to the sea in June, in the dark, each as long as a finger. He thought of the gulls on the bar that took them and the trout that took them. In August the reds that had passed under him would lie

spent on the gravel at the heads of the lakes, every one, because a red salmon spawns once and dies, and the bears and the gulls would take those too. He started a page for bears.

Then he started one for people. He wrote down the children born on the lake since breakup, and the old man on the south shore who would not see freeze-up. He wrote his village on the Nushagak shore, as near as he could now reckon it, house by house. It was past reckoning and he worked at it anyway.

By the twelfth he was sleeping an hour in the day. He did not look unhappy. Dale said afterward that he looked like a man near the bottom of a long column of figures who can see the total coming. He would sit very still on the bucket with his eyes on the lake and the hills behind it, and his lips moved. He was trying to hold it in his head all at one time, everything that was coming into the world and everything going out of it, in the water and on the ground and up on the hills, so that for once the sum would be written down.

Dale did not know what to do. He was twenty. He asked Evon if he was all right, and Evon said he was close. In the house where Evon ate that noon, the woman saw that he left half his tea, which he had never done, and she spoke to her husband about it.

IV. The Fish Rack

Kanakanak · the same afternoon

Anuska was sixty-four that summer. She had buried a husband, who was a helper before Evon was, and she lived in a small house on the bluff at Kanakanak, in sight of the hospital where she had done the washing for thirty years. The Moravian people on the Dillingham side were few then and met where they could, and it was Anuska who kept their book, with the baptisms in the front and the burials in the back. She had the other book too, the cannery tally book with the red spine. It was in a pilot bread tin under her bed.

People came to her. She did not preach, and it was not a thing a woman did among them then. But the ones she had washed in the tub in

1919 were grandparents now, on every river that ran into the bay, and when one of them could not get a thing straight, he found a reason to go to Dillingham.

That afternoon she was at her rack behind the house, cutting reds her grandson had brought up from the beach. Her granddaughter Nettie, who was twelve, hung them as she cut. Anuska slit a fish along the back with the uluaq and opened it and scored the meat, and reached for the next, and stopped with her hand on it.

What is Evon doing today? she said.

Nettie did not know any Evon. Aleknagik was twenty-five miles off, at the far end of a road the state had cut two summers before, and her grandmother had not been up it.

Anuska stood with the knife in her hand and her face turned north. The mosquitoes were bad, and she did not brush at them.

He is counting, she said. *He's trying to count all of it.* She said after a moment, quietly, the way a person says a thing over a child's bad cut, *That's too much for a person.*

She wiped the uluaq on her apron and laid it on the cutting board. She sat down on the gas box beside the rack with her wet hands in her lap and shut her eyes.

Nettie went on hanging fish. She was asked about that hour a good many times in her life and said the same thing each time. Her grandmother sat on the gas box and did not get up from it. Mrs. Olson from the next house came for a loan of salt and saw her there and went away again without it. It was about an hour. Then her grandmother opened her eyes and picked up the knife and finished the fish.

V. The Lard Bucket

The tower · three o'clock

DALE WAS AT THE RAIL WITH THE COUNTER, FOUR MINUTES into the three o'clock count. Evon sat behind him on his bucket with the composition book. There was a second bucket on the platform, where the day man put his lunch.

Dale heard a woman's voice and turned around.

An old woman was sitting on the second bucket. He had not heard the ladder, and the ladder was iron pipe and rang under a cat. She wore a kerchief and a canvas apron wet to the lap, with fish scales on it, and her hands were wet. She was looking at Evon. The day was grey, with cloud down on the hills, and there was a brightness on her that the day did not account for. It was like the shine on the river when the sun gets in under the edge of the cloud. Dale lost his count. It was the only count he lost that summer.

She spoke in Yup'ik and he understood none of it. The words out of the Bible she said in English, the way she had learned them from the Moravians at Carmel, and those he understood. The rest he had from Evon later.

What have you got in the book? she said.

Evon held it out to her. She did not take it. She looked at the open page.

How far have you got?

The fish on this bank since Saturday. The gulls on the bar, nearly. The people on the lake.

And the other bank? And the ones in the nets in the bay this morning? And the ones under the gravel that haven't hatched? She waited. *Last night on this lake a child started in some woman, and the woman doesn't know it yet herself. Have you got that one?*

He said nothing.

> *As thou knowest not what is the way of the wind, nor how the bones do grow in the womb of her that is with child; even so thou knowest not the work of God who doeth all.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 11:5*

You remember my book, she said. *I wrote down every one of you that came off the boat. I thought if I got every name, then somebody would have the count of it. Do you know how many I missed? I don't either. Children died on the beaches*

before any boat came. There were places nobody got to until the next summer. I filled the book, Evon, and it is a small book.

Somebody has to know it, he said.

Somebody does. Two sparrows are sold for a penny, it says, and not one of them shall fall on the ground without your Father. It says without your Father. It doesn't say without Evon Nicolai.

She looked over the rail at the river, where the band was going by with Dale's thumb not on it.

That count is kept. It was kept before there was a tower. It isn't yours, you haven't got the place to stand for it. You have twenty feet of pipe. What did the fish man tell you to do up here?

Ten minutes.

Then that is yours.

> *For thus hath the Lord said unto me, Go, set a watchman; let him declare what he seeth: and when he seeth a troop, horsemen in pairs, a troop of asses, a troop of camels, he shall hearken diligently with much heed. And he cried as a lion: O Lord, I stand continually upon the watch-tower in the day-time, and am set in my ward whole nights;*
>
> *— Isaiah 21:6–8*

What he seeth, she said. *Watch your ten minutes so that not one fish gets by you in them. Be all the way awake for that. Then put the thing down and let the rest go by, and look at it going.* She touched her own chest with a wet hand. *You have been down in the water with them since you were eleven. Come up out of it. A man who does his own watch right gets up to where he can see, and you can see the people better from there. You can look at them and it doesn't drown you.*

Dale looked at the river, because it was past his ten minutes and he did not know what number to write. When he looked back there was one man on the platform. On the lid of the second bucket there was a wet place the size of a woman's two hands, and in it three scales off a red salmon, which dried there and stuck.

VI. The Fifty

Lake Aleknagik · to the end of the run

EVON CLIMBED DOWN AND WENT HOME AND SLEPT UNTIL evening. It was the first whole sleep he had had in a week.

At six he came up the ladder with the composition book in his coat. He gave it to Dale and said to start the stove with it in the morning. Dale did not. He kept it forty years, through a doctorate and a career of counting fish on four rivers, and he showed it to very few people, and to each of them he told about the old woman and the bucket in the same words, leaving nothing out and adding nothing.

That night Evon stood his ten minutes at the top of each hour, and he stood them differently. He set his feet. He did not let his eyes go off the panel. When the lamp on the pole came on for the short dark, he counted under it the same way. Nothing got past him in those ten minutes, up or down, and the biologist came to use Evon Nicolai's sheets as the ones he checked the other towers against. Then he wrote the number, set the counter on the rail, sat down on the bucket, and laid his hands open on his knees.

He watched the fish go by for fifty minutes with nobody's thumb on them. They came up out of the dusk at the bend and crossed the pale panel, four and six abreast, and went on into the lake, where he could not follow them and did not try. Somebody had the number of them, and he found he could leave it there.

• • •

From the tower, in the long light, he could see most of the lake people. He could see the fish camps along both shores with the racks gone red and the smoke lying flat out of the smokehouses. He could see the skiffs, and the children on the gravel bar, and directly below him the rack of Wassily Andrew's wife. Wassily's boat had not come back from the Nushagak flats after the blow on the fourth. She was at the rack every day regardless, cutting, because the fish did not wait on anybody's trouble.

He had looked at that kind of thing all his life from down inside it. Every death on the bay had been his village again, and he had put his head down and counted. Now he stood at the rail and looked at her, and at the rest of them, each house with its own 1919 in it, and the old fist in his chest did not close. He saw them more plainly than he ever had. In the morning he went down and hauled her water and read her the day's text, and ate what she put in front of him, and came back up.

The run thinned after the twentieth. When the state added its sheets that year it had a number for the Wood River, with a comma in it, and the number was good to within a few fish in a hundred. Evon never said it was the fish.

On his last night the lamp came on at eleven. He stood his ten minutes and wrote down nineteen. He set the counter on the rail beside the second bucket, with its three scales, and sat down. Below him a few late reds came up out of the dark water onto the panel, one and then two together, and he let every one of them by.

Background

The verse

> *When the learned man drives away vanity by earnestness, he, the wise, climbing the terraced heights of wisdom, looks down upon the fools, serene he looks upon the toiling crowd, as one that stands on a mountain looks down upon them that stand upon the plain.*
>
> Dhammapada 28, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest. The Elder Mahā Kassapa, a great ascetic who lived in a cave and ate what he was given on his morning round, comes back from his round one day, eats, and sits down to survey with his inner sight all living beings as they are born and die, in the water, on the earth and on the mountains. The Buddha, seated far away, asks himself what Kassapa is doing, sees it, and says that the whole of the rising and falling of beings is beyond a disciple's range: a being is conceived in a womb without even its mother or father knowing, and only a Buddha can know all of it. He sends a radiant image of himself to sit face to face with Kassapa and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa.

Lake Aleknagik, Bristol Bay, Alaska

Bristol Bay, 1919 and 1961

Bristol Bay has the largest sockeye salmon runs in the world, and until the 1950s nobody could say how many fish escaped the commercial nets to spawn. In 1951 a biologist noticed that migrating sockeye could be counted from a high bank at the outlet of Lake Aleknagik on the Wood River, because they travel in narrow bands close to each shore. W. F. Thompson of the University of Washington's Fisheries Research Institute tested counting from towers in 1953, and the Wood River towers have been counted every summer since 1956. The method is a systematic sample: an observer with a hand tally counts for a set part of each hour (ten minutes became the standard) and the count is expanded to the whole hour. Compared against weirs, it proved accurate to within a few percent. Carol Ann Woody's chapter on tower counts gives the history. Alaska became a state in 1959 and took over its fisheries from the federal government in 1960. Powered fishing boats had been illegal in Bristol Bay until 1951, so men of Evon's age had fished it under sail. The road from Dillingham to Aleknagik was built in 1959, and Moravian families had settled the lake's north shore a few years earlier.

The influenza pandemic reached Bristol Bay in the spring of 1919, months after it had burned through the rest of the country, in spite of a winter-long quarantine. It killed adults and largely spared children. When the cannery ships arrived in May they found villages with almost no grown people alive, bodies unburied and loose sled dogs among them. Cannery crews took in the orphaned children for the summer, and in the fall they were sent to the government hospital at Kanakanak, near Dillingham, which grew an orphanage to raise them. No complete count of the dead was ever made. Many Bristol Bay families today descend from those children; Alaska Public Media has an account. The Moravian Church came to southwestern Alaska in 1885 and kept a mission and school called Carmel on the Nushagak from 1886 to 1906. From the start it relied on Yup'ik lay "helpers," who led most village congregations. Evon, Anuska and the others in this story are invented.

After the story of the Elder Mahā Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 28). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

2.6

Neither Cold Nor Hot

Full of all diseases as he is, he fancies himself in perfect health.
— Charles Wesley, "Awake, Thou That Sleepest" (1742)

The way I heard it, on Larkspur Court.

I. The Parlor

Worthington, Ohio · the first Sunday of 1977

The Thursday prayer group met in the church parlor, under a framed print of John Wesley preaching from his father's tombstone, and on the first Sunday of the new year Miss Ruth Bevington stayed after the late service to tell it goodbye until Easter. She was going to her sister's in Bradenton, as she did every winter. She was seventy-four. She had taught arithmetic and English for thirty-eight years at the Methodist girls' school in Lucknow, and when she came home in 1962 the church had given her a dinner and an engraved silver tray and then had not quite known what to do with her, so she had made the Thursday group herself, out of four widows and a percolator.

Jerry Kessler and Walt Mohr waited by the coat rack until the widows had their boots on. They were both in their forties and both in sport coats, and they lived across the court from each other in a subdivision off Morning Street, and they worked at the same engineering firm out on the east side, and they had come to her together because it had been Jerry's idea and Walt had not said no.

She had given the talk at the men's Advent breakfast. She had not said much. She had said that in Lucknow she used to get up before the bells and sit on the roof in the dark, and that it had taken her about eleven years to learn to do it, and that the men in this room had more time on

their hands than they thought. Jerry had been moved. He had gone home and told Barb that the old girl was the real thing.

Miss Bevington, he said now, *Walt and I would like to learn to pray. The way you said. Really learn it.*

She buttoned her coat to the top, which took some time, and looked at the two of them.

Get up before your house does, she said. *Sit in a straight chair. Don't read anything, not even the Bible. Watch.*

Watch what? said Jerry.

You'll find out. Come and tell me at Easter.

Jerry wrote it on the back of the bulletin in the parking lot, against the roof of the Pontiac, while the wind came across the Green: *Early. Chair. No reading. Watch.* Walt didn't write anything. He stood with his hands in his coat pockets and looked at the white steeple and the sky behind it, which was the color of an old nickel.

II. Sixty-Five

Pruitt & Hale, Consulting Engineers · January and February

That was the coldest January anybody in Ohio could remember. The pipelines could not carry gas north fast as the state was burning it, and Columbia Gas cut back the factories, and then the schools, and then asked everybody else please. Ohio State called off a whole day of classes to save fuel. In Dayton the General Motors plants sent twenty-six thousand men home. In Worthington the school board talked about running Saturdays in June. The landlord at the office park put a locked plastic box over every thermostat in the building and set them all at sixty-five.

Jerry had been the office manager at Pruitt & Hale for nine years. It said *Administration* on his door, which meant the keys, the payroll, the postage meter, the Bunn coffee maker, the softball team, the bowling league, and the big cardboard United Way thermometer in the lobby, which he colored in with a red marker every Friday. The building was one story of brown brick and smoked glass in a row of others just like it, set

down in what had been a soybean field, with a retention pond out front that froze solid that winter and had three ducks standing on it most mornings like they had been told to wait.

He did get up before his house. He set the alarm for a quarter past five and turned it off before it could wake Barb and went down and sat in a chair from the dinette set, as he had been told, with the house at fifty-five degrees and the refrigerator humming. He sat there a few minutes. Then he thought of the pipes in the drafting room, which ran along the north wall and had frozen the year before, and of the coffee, and of the young men who would come in at half past seven to a cold building, and he got up and got his coat.

He was at the office every day by a quarter after six. He started both pots. He plugged in the space heater he had brought from his own basement, which was against the landlord's rules, and stood it in the middle of the drafting room where the boys could get at it, and by the time they came in stamping their feet he had the coffee poured. They stood around the heater with their hands out, Denny and Kurt and the Riegel boy and Patty, who did the lettering on the small sheets, and Jerry talked to them about Woody Hayes and the Orange Bowl and whether the Reds could do it three years running, and about the energy crisis, and about their mothers, and they liked him. Everybody liked Jerry. He knew what everybody's kids were named.

And all the time, pouring coffee, carrying the heater, scraping the ice off the inside of the windows with a putty knife, he said it to himself. *Watch.* He was watching. He was watching everything, the thermostat and the pond and the kids and the pipes. He figured he was a man who prayed on the go, the way his father had been. He figured the Lord could hear him over a coffee maker.

Walt came in at five minutes to eight. He hung his coat on the same hook he had used for eleven years and went to his board by the north windows, the biggest board in the room, with the parallel bar he had brought from his last job and a coffee can of pencils sharpened with a knife. He was the chief draftsman. He lettered every title block in the place by hand, slowly, turning the pencil a little between his fingers as he

drew so the line stayed the same width from end to end, and the young men said you could set a ruler against a Walt Mohr letter. He did not stand around the heater. He wore a gray sweater his wife had knitted. Down the hall the blueline machine ran all day, and the whole back of the building smelled faintly of ammonia, and he did not seem to notice that either.

At half past four he went home. In the evenings, after supper, he put on his old Navy peacoat and walked. He walked the court and out to Morning Street and around by the elementary school and back, slowly, in the dark and the cold, with his hands at his sides, for about an hour. At ten his house went dark.

One morning toward the end of January he stopped in the coffee room on his way to the board. Jerry was refilling the sugar.

Jer, he said. *That isn't it.*

What isn't what?

She said sit.

I sit. I sit plenty. Jerry laughed. *Walt, I pray all day long. I just do it on the go. I figure the Lord isn't particular about chairs.*

You can't do it on the side, Walt said. *It's not something you do on the side of something else.*

Now you sound like my mother.

Walt looked at him a while longer. Then he took his coffee and went back down the hall, and Patty, who was coming the other way, heard him say to nobody, *He doesn't want to be told,* and then he sat down at the north windows and went on lettering a title block, and that was all he said about it.

• • •

On the second of February the new president came on television in a tan cardigan sweater, sitting by a fire, and asked everybody to keep their thermostats at sixty-five in the daytime and fifty-five at night. Jerry already had. He told everyone at the office he already had.

The bowling league met Friday nights at the lanes on Route 23. Pruitt & Hale had two teams, and Jerry was captain of one and kept the books

for both. Walt bowled on the other. That Friday Walt bowled his two games and put his ball back in its bag at nine o'clock and got his coat.

Going home to bed? Jerry said, loud enough for the alley. *She gave you a job of work, Walt. Shouldn't you be up nights praying?*

The men laughed, and Walt smiled and went out to his car. Jerry bowled a two-twelve in the third game, his best since October, and stayed until they closed, and drove home at half past twelve under a sky so clear and cold it made the streetlights ring, and fell into bed beside Barb and slept like a stone until a quarter past five.

III. Four-Thirty

Larkspur Court · February into March

WALT GOT UP AT HALF PAST FOUR. HE DID NOT SET AN ALARM. He had been a Navy man and he woke when he decided to. He went down in his socks so as not to wake Lois and took the straight chair from the end of the kitchen table and turned it toward the window over the sink, and sat.

For the first weeks it was nothing but trouble. He fell asleep sitting up and woke with his chin on his chest. He planned drawings. He lettered in his head, a whole sheet of a sewage plant for the city of Marion, and when he caught himself his right hand was moving on his knee. He argued with Jerry. He argued with Jerry a good deal. He thought about his daughter in Toledo, and his knee, and money. Every time he found himself gone he came back, the way you bring a pencil back to the edge of the bar when it has wandered, without making a fuss about it, and was gone again inside a minute.

The house was fifty-five degrees. He could see his breath, almost. The furnace came on under the floor with a thump and a tick and ran a while and went off. The refrigerator hummed and quit. Far off, on 161, a truck went west, and he could follow the sound of it a long way. He did not try to make anything happen. Miss Bevington had not told him to make anything happen. She had told him to watch, and he had decided early that

he would take her at her word, which was how he took a set of specifications.

He did not tell anybody. He did not tell Lois, who thought he had taken up getting up early the way some men take up golf.

It came in the middle of March, on a morning when the thaw had started and the gutter over the back step was dripping. He did not know afterward when it had begun. He was listening to the gutter, the drops coming off it one at a time onto the concrete, and at some point the listening had nobody in it. There was the drop, and the dark, and the hum, and a pair of hands lying open on two knees that were his. There was the next drop. It went on. When the paper hit the storm door at twenty to six it was still going on, and he got up and filled the percolator and put it on the burner, and it went on while he did that, and while he shaved, and while he drove to work behind a salt truck on Morning Street with the window cracked to keep the windshield clear.

It was still there at the board. He lettered the title block of a bridge deck for Delaware County, and he saw every letter all the way through, from the first touch of the lead to the lift, and each one was the only letter there had ever been.

Patty noticed he was humming. She told Denny, and Denny said Walt Mohr didn't hum, and went to listen, and came back and said he'd be darned.

IV. The Rail

Miss Bevington's front room, Old Worthington · Easter afternoon, April 10

SHE LIVED IN FOUR ROOMS OF A WHITE FRAME HOUSE TWO blocks off the Green, with a brass bowl from Lucknow on the radiator and a photograph on the wall of a woman in a dark dress standing with about forty girls in white in front of a long porch. She had come home brown from Florida. They brought her an Easter lily in foil from the church, and she put it on the radiator next to the bowl and sat down across from them with her hands in her lap.

Well, she said. *Did you watch?*

Jerry answered first. He had been thinking about how to say it all the way over.

Miss Bevington, I'll be honest with you, because I know Walt won't mind. I'm a little worried about him. He's in bed by ten every night. I can see his house from my front window. Lights out, ten o'clock, like a farmer. He bowls two games and goes home. He smiled at Walt to show there were no hard feelings. Walt was looking at the lily.

And you, Jerry?

I was up at five-fifteen every morning. I don't believe I missed three days all winter. I had the coffee on at the office by half past six in the coldest January in the history of the state of Ohio. I said that word to myself, I bet you, a hundred times a day. I don't believe I slept in once.

She looked at him for a long time, the way she had looked at forty girls on a porch.

Jerry, she said. *You were warm all winter.*

He started to answer and did not. She turned a little in her chair toward the window, where the afternoon was coming down yellow across the wet lawns.

My father kept trotters and pacers at the fairgrounds, when the fair was still down at Powell, she said. *He had one good pacer at a time, when he could afford one. And he had an old mare named Dolly who pulled the milk wagon, and every morning he put her on the track beside the pacer to keep him company, because a racehorse is lonesome. And Dolly went round and round on the inside rail, sweating, very busy, blowing like a steam engine. She worked harder than any horse on that track. And the pacer went by her like she was a fence post.*

She looked back at Jerry.

You took your busy for watching. That's all. It's the commonest thing there is. I did it for eleven years.

Then she got up and went to the bookcase, slowly, holding the backs of chairs, and came back with a black book whose spine had been mended with adhesive tape, and opened it where a strip of newspaper marked the place. She read it to him the way she must once have read arithmetic problems to girls who were afraid of them, slowly and without any particular expression, as if it were just information.

> *If this sleeper be not outwardly vicious, his sleep is usually the deepest of all: whether he be of the Laodicean spirit, "neither cold nor hot," but a quiet, rational, inoffensive, good-natured professor of the religion of his fathers...*
>
> *— Charles Wesley, "Awake, Thou That Sleepest," sermon before the University of Oxford, April 4, 1742*

Jerry's face had gone red to the ears. He sat with the bulletin from the first Sunday of the year still folded in his inside pocket, where he had carried it for three months, and he could feel the corner of it against his chest.

Walter? she said.

I got up, Walt said.

She looked at him, and nodded, and did not ask him anything else. The three of them sat a while in the front room with the lily. Then she said she was tired from the trip, and they got their coats.

V. The Window

Larkspur Court · the next morning

Jerry woke in the dark without the alarm. The clock said four thirty-one. He lay a while listening to Barb breathe and then got up and went down the stairs in his robe and stood at the front window.

The court was dark. Eleven houses in a horseshoe, their porch lights off, their station wagons nosed up to their garage doors, the wet lawns gray in the light from the one streetlamp at the mouth of the court. Every window black but one. Across the way, at the side of the Mohrs' house, the kitchen light was on, and it lay out on the driveway in a long yellow square.

He could not see Walt. He could only see the light.

He thought about going over. He thought he could take the percolator, and stand at the back door, and they could have a cup. He stood with his hand on the cold glass and did not go. After a while he went into his own kitchen without turning on the light and pulled a chair out from the

dinette set, and the legs scraped on the linoleum and he winced and waited to hear if Barb had woken, and she had not. He sat down facing the window over the sink. He did not know what he was supposed to be watching. He could see, past the corner of the garage, a piece of the yellow square on the Mohrs' driveway, and he watched that.

The furnace came on under the floor and ran and went off. A truck went west on 161. The paper hit the Mohrs' storm door at twenty to six, and then his own, and he was still sitting there.

Background

The verse

> *Earnest among the thoughtless, awake among the sleepers, the wise man advances like a racer, leaving behind the hack.*
>
> Dhammapada 29, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two monks receive a meditation subject from the Buddha and go off together to a forest hermitage for the rains. One spends his evenings bringing firewood, tending the charcoal brazier and chatting with the young monks, and goes to bed when his friend comes in from walking meditation. The other warns him once ("the favor of the Buddhas may not be won by double-dealing"), gives up when he will not be told, walks in the first watch of the night, rests in the second, rises in the third, and soon reaches arahatship. When they return, the busy one tells the Buddha that his friend did nothing but sleep, and that he himself never did. The Buddha answers that he has mistaken heedlessness for heedfulness, and compares him to a worn-out hack beside a racehorse. Read the full commentary story, or about appamāda, the heedfulness the second chapter of the Dhammapada is named for.

Worthington, Ohio

Central Ohio, 1977

The winter of 1976–77 was one of the coldest on record in the eastern United States, and interstate pipelines could not deliver natural gas as fast as the cold burned it. Across Ohio, gas companies curtailed industrial customers and schools; the Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland reported in February that schools in its district had closed widely, that General Motors had laid off nearly 26,000 workers in the Dayton area for several days, and that some 110,000 manufacturing workers had been idled. Ohio State cancelled classes on January 18 at the request of Columbia Gas and the electric company to save fuel. On February 2, two weeks after his inauguration, President Carter gave his first fireside chat, wearing a cardigan, and asked Americans to keep their thermostats at 65 degrees in the daytime and 55 at night.

Worthington was founded in 1803 by the Scioto Company, a band of settlers from Granby, Connecticut, led by James Kilbourne, who laid it out around a New England village green; by the 1970s it was a prosperous suburb on the north edge of Columbus. Drafting offices of the period still drew by hand and reproduced their sheets on the diazo or "blueline" process, developed in ammonia fumes. Miss Bevington's school stands in for the Methodist women's mission in Lucknow that grew into Isabella Thoburn College, founded in 1870 by the first woman missionary the Methodist Episcopal Church sent to India. Her father's fair ran at Powell until 1937, when it moved to Delaware, where the Little Brown Jug for three-year-old pacers has been run since 1946. Charles Wesley, the hymn writer, preached "Awake, Thou That Sleepest" before the University of Oxford in 1742; it became the third of the standard sermons of Methodism.

After the story of the two friends, one heedful and one heedless, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 29). The original. Scripture from Charles Wesley's sermon "Awake, Thou That Sleepest" (1742), in the 1872 edition of the Wesleys' sermons. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.7

Caliche

Contra Pereza, Diligencia.
— Ripalda, Catecismo de la doctrina cristiana

Así me lo platicaron, at the gate of the transfer yards.

I. Saint Macario's Day

Nuevo Laredo, Tamaulipas · January 2, 2019, before light

Magali Lizcano had a degree in foreign trade from Monterrey and a desk in her father's customs agency, and on the second morning of the year she was standing in the dark at the gate of the transfer yards with a folder of pedimentos under her arm, because a driver had gone home with the wrong ones.

It was cold. A norther had come down in the night. Forty or fifty men stood around an oil drum with a mesquite fire in it, on a piece of ground that was swept and level and as big as a threshing floor. At the edge of the light doña Alba had her table, her two pots and her comal. She had sold breakfast at that gate since before Magali was born: flour tortillas with egg and dried beef, with beans, with potato, and coffee boiled with cinnamon in a blue enamel pot. The men ate standing. This morning each of them, before he drank, tipped a little of his coffee onto the ground.

For don Maca, one of them said. *It's his saint's day.*

He doesn't need it. Up there he has his own yard, ten thousand leagues across, and his thirty-three with him, and no line at the bridge.

And a truck as long as from here to Monterrey.

That one I've seen, doña Alba said, turning a tortilla. Nobody laughed.

Magali had heard of Macario all her life, the way a person hears of the Revolution. The yards swore by him. They said he had the first place in heaven among men who work, and they could tell you how many gates it had. She had always taken it for the kind of thing men say around a fire. But doña Alba was not a woman who said things.

When the drivers had gone to their trucks, Magali bought a coffee she did not want.

Doña Alba. Did you really see him? Macario?

I saw him. I gave him his breakfast for twelve years.

The man, yes. But the one they talk about, with the leagues and the thirty-three. That has to be somebody else, something they made up and hung his name on. A thing like that is not easy to see.

All the same, I know him, doña Alba said. *I know what he is, and I know what made him that. Sit down, you're in the smoke.*

There was an upturned bucket. Magali sat.

You know how it is here, nobody has only one name. He was Macario, so he was Maca. He stood godfather at every baptism in four colonias, and gave, so they called him el Padrino. He said usted to everybody, to boys, to drunks, to the dog, so they called him Usted. He never let a man sleep in the street, so he was Posadas. He could hold a thousand things in his head at once, every trailer in the yard and which broker had its papers, so he was Mil Ojos. He was married to Geni, so the women called him el de la Geni. And he was the head of thirty-three men, and you have heard what they called that.

And there were seven things he kept as long as he lived. I can say them, because I watched him. He kept his mother and father, every Friday, by money order to the rancho. He gave the old people their place. He spoke softly. He carried no tales from one man to another. His hand was open; ask him, and it was already in his pocket. He said what was so. And he did not get angry, and when he felt it come up in him he put it down again quickly, like a man setting down something hot.

That's all?

That's all. Do you want to hear how it went, or do you have to be somewhere?

Magali had to be at the office at eight. It was a quarter to six.

II. A Place to Stand

The yards · the winter of 1995

THIS IS WHAT SHE TOLD.

He came the winter after the peso fell, from a rancho past Anáhuac, with one change of clothes. The work was transfers. A man hooked a trailer on this side, stood in line for the bridge, dropped it at a yard on the other side and came back for the next one, and he was paid by the crossing. But first he had to be given a trailer, and for that he stood at this gate in the dark with two hundred others and waited for the checker to call him.

In those days the ground here was ruts. When it rained it was soup, and when it froze it was knives. The first morning, Macario scraped a place flat with the side of his boot, big enough for his two feet, and stood in it. A man came up, put a shoulder into him and took the place. Macario said nothing. He moved over and scraped another. A second man shouldered him out of that. He scraped a third. One after another they came out of the dark and pushed him off whatever he had made, and by the time the checker opened his window there was a row of flat places along the fence with a man standing in each, and Macario at the end of the row in the ruts.

He looked down the row. *They all seem pleased,* he said to himself. *If it makes them that glad, it must be a good thing to be doing.*

The next morning he brought a shovel. He came at three and leveled a piece of ground as big as a threshing floor, this ground, and when the men came they all stood on it. When the northers started he found an oil drum and cut mesquite, and they stood around that. It got so a man would sooner wait here than anywhere.

Then he considered the brecha. It was a league and more of dirt from the yards out to the pavement, and it broke springs and kingpins, and where the mesquite and the huisache leaned in they took the mirrors off and tore the tarps. So he began getting up earlier. Before the gate, he was out on the brecha with the shovel and a wheelbarrow of caliche, filling holes, and with an axe, taking off the limbs.

A man named Chuy Rentería came along and stopped. *What are you doing, Usted?* They were calling him that already.

Making my road to heaven.

Then I'm with you.

Come on. Heaven has room for plenty.

A third man saw the two of them and asked the same thing and got the same answer. Then there was a fourth, and it went on that way until there were thirty-three. They worked with shovels and axes, and they made that road smooth and level, a league of it and then two, all the way out to the pavement.

III. The Dina

The brecha · 1996

There was a delegate in the yards then. He was supposed to speak for the drivers. What he did was keep a beer depot across from the gate, with a back room of slot machines, and the men who drank there were the men the checker called first.

Now he looked across the road in the mornings and saw his customers standing around a fire with doña Alba's coffee, and thirty-three of them not there at all, because they were out on the brecha with shovels. He thought: *These men have got hold of the wrong work. If they would go out to the ranches for cabrito, and drink, and play the machines, I would make something off them.*

He sent for them. *What is it you're doing out there?*

Making a road to heaven, jefe.

That is no work for men with families. Bring in meat from the monte, have your beer, enjoy yourselves a little.

They would not. The more he pressed them, the more they would not. So he got angry, and he said to himself, I'll finish them. He went to the Comandante. *There is a gang of thieves working the brecha at night. They stop the trailers with shovels in their hands, as if they were mending the road.*

It was a thing that happened on other roads, and the Comandante did not look into it. *Bring them,* he said. When they were brought, thirty-three

men with their wrists tied in their own bootlaces, he looked them over once. *Lay them in the road and put the truck over them.*

They were laid down in the caliche, on the road they had made. Macario turned his head and spoke along the row.

Friends, we have nothing to stand on now but good will. So be easy. Don't be angry with anybody. Wish the Comandante well, and the delegate, and the truck, and the man who is driving it.

They did as he said.

The truck was a gray Dina tractor that the Comandante's people kept for dragging wrecks. The driver brought it down the brecha in low gear, and forty meters from the first man it stopped. He said afterward that it had not stalled. The engine was running. It stood there shaking and would not come on, whatever he did with his feet.

They told the Comandante. *The driver can see they are men, that is all it is,* he said. *Cover them with tarps and bring it again.* So they pulled the tarps off three trailers and covered the thirty-three from one end to the other, and backed the Dina off a kilometer and brought it down again in the dark. It was still a long way off when it swung around in the road, the whole length of it, and went back the way it had come. The driver swore before the Virgin that the wheel had turned in his hands.

When the Comandante heard that, he thought, there is something behind this. He had them untied and stood up in front of him.

Friends, have I ever kept back anything that was owed to you?

Comandante, what do you mean?

I am told that you are thieves, and that you rob on the brecha.

Who says it?

The delegate.

We are not thieves, Comandante. We are making ourselves a road to heaven, and we do one thing and another along the way. The delegate wanted us for his beer and his machines. We would not come, and so he told you this.

The Comandante was quiet for some time. *A piece of iron knew what you were,* he said, *and I am a Christian and did not. Forgive me.*

He took the depot from the delegate and set him to work for the thirty-three, him and his wife and his sons. He gave them the Dina. And

he gave them the brecha and the corner where it met the pavement, to do with as they saw fit. The thirty-three said to one another, *Look at that. Even in this life it comes back.* For a week they took turns driving the Dina around the colonia, three in the cab and the rest standing on the frame, blowing the horn.

IV. Justa's Beam

The crossing · 1997

WHEN THEY WERE TIRED OF THAT, THEY TALKED IT OVER. *We ought to do more. What should it be?* They settled on a paradero, a resting place, at the crossing where four roads came together, for anybody who came down any one of them. It would be built strong, with a roof that would stand. They sent for a master builder, don Artemio, who had put up half the churches between here and Sabinas.

They also agreed among themselves that this was men's business, and the women were to have no part in it.

Now there were four women in Macario's house: his sisters Justa, Lety and Clara, and his wife, Geni.

Justa went to don Artemio by herself, with money tied in a handkerchief. *Maestro, see to it that the biggest share in this building is mine.*

It can be done, he said. He went out into the monte and marked a mesquite for the main beam, and cut it, and laid it up to cure. When it was cured he hewed it and planed it and bored it for the pegs, and along the face of it he cut letters with a chisel: ESTE ES EL PARADERO DE JUSTA. Then he wrapped it in a tarp and left it in her yard.

The walls went up. The day came to close the roof, and don Artemio took off his hat. *Señores, there is one thing we forgot.*

What thing?

The main beam.

Then we'll cut one.

You cannot hang a roof on green mesquite. It twists, and takes the walls with it. This wants a beam that was cut a long time ago and has done its curing.

Then what do we do?

If somebody in the colonia had one put by, already worked, and would sell it, that is the thing to look for.

They looked everywhere and found it in Justa's yard, and offered her a thousand pesos. She would not take a thousand.

Give me a share in the paradero, she said, *and I'll give you the beam.*

We agreed the women would have no part in it.

Don Artemio put his hat back on. *Señores, what are you doing? Outside of the Eternal Father's own glory, I do not know of a place where women don't come in. Take the beam and let me finish.*

So they took it, and he closed the roof. They made three rooms under it: one for the licenciados and the big men when they came through, one for the poor, and one for the sick.

Then the thirty-three built thirty-three benches, one apiece, along the front wall, and they gave the Dina its orders. If a stranger came and sat down on a bench, the Dina was to carry him to the house of the man who had built that bench, and that man was to see his feet washed and his back rubbed, and feed him, and give him a bed. And so it went. People came off the buses from the other side with their belongings in a plastic bag, the ones who had been put back across. Drivers came whose trucks had died, and women looking for somebody. Whichever bench they dropped onto, the Dina would be standing there with its door open, and that night they slept in a house.

Macario planted an ebony beside the paradero, and under it he set a bench of stone.

Everyone who came in looked up and read the beam. *This is Justa's paradero,* they said. The names of the thirty-three were not written anywhere.

Lety thought: *They shut us out, and Justa got in anyway by being clever. I ought to do something too.* And she thought: people who come here should have water to drink and water to wash in. She had a tank raised, and a place dug and tiled, with showers.

Clara thought: *Justa gave a beam and Lety gave water. What is left for me?* And she thought: when they have drunk and washed and are ready to leave, they should not leave bare. She laid out a garden, with orange and

lime and pomegranate, fig, roses of Castile, bougainvillea, basil, rue. Nobody could name a thing that flowers or bears and say it was not in Clara's garden. Every driver who pulled out had a sprig on his dashboard.

Geni thought: *I am the daughter of his mother's brother, and I am his wife besides. What he does is mine, and what I do is his.* So she did nothing. She did her hair and her nails.

And Macario went on keeping his seven things, the ones I told you. When his days were counted out, he died, and he came into the country of the Thirty-Three as the head of it. His companions came there after him. Don Artemio came there too, and he builds for them still.

V. The Country of the Thirty-Three

No date

There were people in that country already, old residents, and when they heard that new ones had come they made a welcome and brought out their best drink. Macario passed the word down his men that nobody was to touch it. The old residents drank it themselves and got drunk. Macario thought, why would I share a country with these? He made a sign, and the thirty-three took them by the heels and pitched them over the edge, and they fell headfirst into the sea at the bottom of the mountain. Even so, they had something to their credit. A town came up for them down there, and a tree with it, the yellow trumpet-flower that people here call tronadora.

When that was over, the city of the Thirty-Three stood up. It is ten thousand leagues from the east gate to the west, and the same from north to south, and it has a thousand gates, and gardens, and tanks of water. In the middle of it, as the fruit of the paradero, is a house called Victory. It is seven hundred leagues high. It flies banners three hundred leagues long, gold banners on jeweled poles and jeweled banners on gold poles.

From the ebony he planted, there came up a coral tree, a colorín, a hundred leagues around. From the stone bench there came, at the foot of that tree, a seat of yellow stone, sixty leagues long and fifty wide and fif-

teen thick. When he sits on it, it goes down half its depth, and when he gets up it comes back, like the seat of a Kenworth.

The Dina is there. They have no trucks in that country and no use for them, so most days it goes about as one of the people. But when they go out to the garden for a holiday, it turns into a truck again, a hundred and fifty leagues long. It makes thirty-three tankers, one for each of them, and every tanker is most of a league around. In the middle it makes one for Macario, called Good-to-See, thirty leagues around, with a canopy over it twelve leagues across, all precious stones, and along the edge of the canopy little bells that the wind plays like a conjunto with all five instruments. Every tanker has seven axles. Every axle carries seven ponds, every pond seven lily plants, every plant seven flowers, every flower seven petals, and on every petal seven girls are dancing a polka.

Magali laughed. Doña Alba let her, and went on.

When Justa died, she came there, and with her there came a hall nine hundred leagues long, called Justa's, and no place is lovelier. On the eighth of every month the doctrine is taught in it. To this day, when drivers see a fine place anywhere, they say, *It looks like Justa's.* When Lety died, she came there, and with her a lake called Lety, five hundred leagues across. When Clara died, she came there, and with her a grove of vines called Clara's, where they take the ones whose time is nearly up, and walk with them, and are glad.

Geni died, and she was born a heron, in a cut bank on the river.

VI. Pepinos

The river, and afterward

MACARIO LOOKED OVER HIS HOUSEHOLD. JUSTA WAS THERE, and Lety, and Clara. Where had Geni come out? He looked, and saw her standing on one leg in the Río Bravo. He thought: *The foolish girl did nothing, and now she is a bird. I will have to get her to do something, and bring her here.*

He put off his own looks and went down to her as somebody else. *What are you doing here?*

Who are you, señor?

Your husband, Macario.

Where did you come out?

In the country of the Thirty-Three. Do you know where your sisters-in-law are?

No.

They are there too, in my house. Would you like to see them?

How would I get there?

I'll carry you. He set her on the palm of his hand and carried her up, and put her down on the shore of the lake called Lety. Then he went to the three. *Would you like to see Geni?*

Where is she?

On the shore of Lety's lake.

They went and looked. *Ay, look what the señora got for all those hours at the mirror. Look at the beak on her. Look at the feet. Look at those legs. Doesn't she look lovely?* And when they had said it, they went away.

Macario came back to her. *Did you see them?*

I saw them. They laughed at me and left. Take me back.

He took her back and set her in the water. *Did you see how they live?*

I saw.

You could live that way. If I tell you how, will you keep to it?

I will keep to it.

So he gave her five cares to keep, *cuidados* he called them: to take no life, to take nothing that was not given her, to keep faith in her own bed, to say nothing that was not so, and to drink nothing that would cloud her head. *Don't get careless,* he said, and went.

A heron lives on fish. After that she walked the sandbars for the ones that had died on their own, and ate only those. A few days later he came to try her. He made himself a fish and lay on his back on the sand as if he were dead. She took him up in her beak. As she went to swallow he flicked his tail, and the moment she felt it she put him back in the water. He waited a little and lay down in front of her again. Again she picked him up, and again the tail moved, and she let him go. He did it three times.

Then he stood up as himself. *I came to try you. You are keeping them well. Go on as you are, and before long you will be in my house. Don't get careless.*

From then on she ate fish that had died on their own, or she ate nothing. In a few days she dried up and died, and for that alone she was born again as a potter's daughter in Dolores Hidalgo.

When she was fifteen or sixteen he looked for her, and found her there, and thought, now I should go.

Doña Alba, Magali said. *He has been dead twelve years. The girl is sixteen.*

You are counting by the wrong clock, doña Alba said, and turned a tortilla.

He loaded a truck with the seven kinds of precious stones, made to look like cucumbers, and drove into Dolores crying, *Pepinos! Come and get your pepinos!*

People came out with money in their hands. *I don't sell them,* he said.

Then how do you let them go?

I give them to the woman who keeps her cuidados.

Cuidados, señor? What sort of thing is that? Are they black, are they brown, what color do they come in?

You don't know what they are, so you are not likely to be keeping them. My pepinos go to the woman who keeps hers.

Señor, there is a potter's girl who goes around all day saying, I keep my cuidados, I keep my cuidados. Give them to her.

The girl came. *Then give them to me.*

Who are you?

Somebody who has never once let them drop.

It was for you I brought the load. He drove to her father's door and unloaded there, in the shape of cucumbers, the kind of wealth nobody can carry off, and he told her who he was. *Here is enough to live on. Keep the five whole.* And he went.

When that life was done, she was born down below among the old residents, the ones who had been thrown out. She was the daughter of their chief, who hated Macario worse than any of them did. And since she had kept her cares through two lives running, she was something to look at. Her skin was the color of gold. The young men down there all came asking, and her father sent every one of them away. *You are not fit for her. She*

will choose for herself. He called them together in one place and put a wreath of flowers in her hand. *Pick the one who suits you.*

Macario saw it from above. He made himself an old man of that people and went and stood at the back.

She looked one way and the other. Then she saw him, and because she had lived with him before, it came over her like a river coming down an arroyo. *That one is my husband,* she said, and she threw the wreath over his head.

The old residents were ashamed. *All this time the chief cannot find a man good enough, and now he has found one. This fellow could be her grandfather.* They started for home with their heads down.

He took her by the hand. *I am Macario,* he shouted, and he went straight up into the air.

The old man has made fools of us! And they were after him.

Matías, who drives for him, came along with the truck called Victory and stopped in the road, and Macario lifted her in, and they set out for the city. The way went through a forest of ceibas. The trees were full of nests, and the young eagles in them heard the truck coming and began to scream.

What is that crying?

Young eagles, jefe.

Why are they crying?

They hear the truck. They think it will bring the trees down and crush them.

Then don't let so many die on account of one man. Turn it around.

Matías had a thousand horses under the hood. He gave them the sign, and the truck came about and headed back toward the ones who were chasing it.

They saw it coming. *The old man ran out of our town, and now he has turned around. He must have got help.* They went back down the road they had come up, and into their town, and they never lifted their heads again.

He brought her into the city and set her over twenty-five million dancers. One day she asked him for something. *In this country I have no mother or father, no brother or sister. Wherever you go, take me. I will,* he said, and he has.

Ever since, when the tronadora blooms down below, the old residents say, *Our colorín is in flower,* and come up the mountain to fight. So he keeps guards along the way. And at the gates of the city he has set up figures of himself with the lightning in his hand, the way you would stand a scarecrow in a man's own shirt. When the old residents get that far and see them, they say, *Macario has come out,* and run.

VII. The Seventh One

The gate · sunup

THE SKY OVER THE RIVER HAD GONE THE COLOR OF THE INSIDE of a shell. A line of trailers was already moving on the road.

So that is Macario, doña Alba said. She was scraping the comal. *He took the road of not getting careless. It was the only road he had, and it got him the charge of two countries. You went to catechism?*

With the Ripalda.

Then say me the seven that stand against the seven.

Magali had not said them since she was nine. They came out in order, as if they had been stacked somewhere.

Contra estos siete vicios hay siete virtudes.

Contra Soberbia, Humildad.
Contra Avaricia, Largueza.
Contra Lujuria, Castidad.
Contra Ira, Paciencia.
Contra Gula, Templanza.
Contra Envidia, Caridad.
Contra Pereza, Diligencia.

P. Qué cosa es Pereza?
R. Andar con tristeza y tedio en las cosas divinas.
P. Y Diligencia qué es?
R. Presteza, y gozo de todo esto.

— Ripalda, Catecismo de la doctrina cristiana (Madrid, 1850)

The seventh one, doña Alba said. *Against sloth, diligence. Everybody praises it, and everybody has a hard word for the one who lets things slide. And what is it? Quickness, and gladness in the whole business. That was him. Go on now, you'll be late.*

Magali drove out by the old brecha, which had been pavement for twenty years. At the crossing the ebony was still standing, with the stone bench under it. She had passed the building beside it a thousand times and had never looked up under the porch to read the beam. She read it.

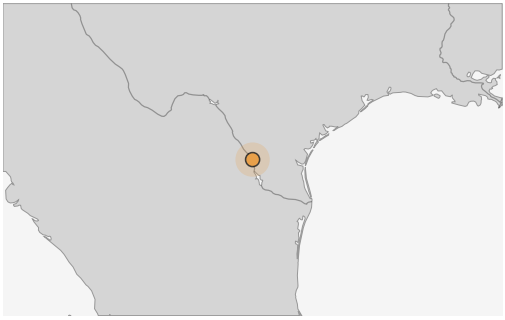
A little way on there was a hole in the right lane the size of a washtub, and the trucks were swinging out around it one after another. She had gone around it herself every morning since November. She stopped in the lane with her flashers on and eleven trailers behind her leaning on their horns, and got down in her office shoes to see what there was to put in it.

Background

The verse

> *By earnestness did Maghavan (Indra) rise to the lordship of the gods. People praise earnestness; thoughtlessness is always blamed.*
>
> Dhammapada 30, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young noble named Mahāli asks the Buddha whether he has really seen Sakka, king of the gods, or only some counterfeit. The Buddha answers that he knows Sakka and what made him Sakka, explains each of his names, lists the seven vows he kept, and tells his past life. As the villager Magha he cleared a place to stand, was shoved out of it, and cleared another; then he mended the road, and thirty-two others joined him. A headman who profited from drink denounced them as thieves, and the king had them laid before an elephant, which would not trample them. Pardoned, they built a rest-house at the crossroads and shut the women out of the work, but Sudhammā got her name on its roof-pinnacle, Nandā dug a bathing pool and Cittā planted a garden. Sujātā did nothing, and was reborn as a crane. Reborn as lord of the Thirty-Three, Magha tested the crane with a fish that was not dead, brought her jewels disguised as cucumbers when she was a potter's daughter, and at last carried her off from the house of his enemies, turning his chariot back in mid-flight so as not to crush a forest of nestlings. Read the full commentary story.



Nuevo Laredo, Tamaulipas

The two Laredos, 1995–2019

The North American Free Trade Agreement took effect on January 1, 1994, and that December the peso collapsed; the recession of 1995 sent people north to the border for work. Laredo, Texas, and Nuevo Laredo, Tamaulipas, became the busiest inland port in North America. Freight does not simply drive across. A long-haul truck drops its trailer in a yard on one side, and a short-haul tractor, called a transfer, pulls it over the bridge to a yard on the other; the drivers, many of them from Nuevo Laredo, are paid by the crossing and spend much of the day in line. Until the World Trade Bridge was completed in April 2000, most trucks used a single commercial lane on the downtown bridge, and the line could run for miles. The pedimento is the Mexican customs declaration that travels with each load. The yards, the brecha, the paradero and everyone in this story are invented, and no such order by any comandante is recorded.

The catechism of the Spanish Jesuit Jerónimo de Ripalda, first printed at Burgos in 1591, was reprinted hundreds of times and carried all over Spanish America; generations of Mexican children learned their doctrine from "the Ripalda" by heart, in questions and answers. The lines here follow a Madrid printing of 1850, with its punctuation. January 2 is one of the days kept for Saint Macarius. Texas ebony, ébano, is the evergreen shade tree of the lower Rio Grande. The colorín is a coral tree, kin to the tree that stands in Sakka's heaven in the old story, and the tronadora is the yellow trumpet-flower that grows wild on both banks. A Dina was a truck built by Mexico's state-owned Diesel Nacional.

After the story of Mahāli's questions from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 30). The original. Catechism from Jerónimo de Ripalda, Catecismo de la doctrina cristiana (Madrid, 1850 printing), in Spanish. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

2.8

The Closed Cone

During the calm season of Indian summer the fire creeps quietly along the ground, feeding on the needles and cones.
— John Muir, The Yosemite

Here's how I heard it, at the Madison amphitheater.

I. The Cone

Mammoth Hot Springs, Yellowstone · June 1988

On the last night of training, Ardis Hollister gave each of the new seasonals one thing.

She was sixty-four and had taught botany for thirty years at the college in Kearney, Nebraska, and spent twenty-six summers in the park in the gray shirt and the flat hat, and she did it every year. A girl from Ohio got a feather from a raven. A Navajo kid from Window Rock who wanted to be a geologist got a chip of obsidian. A retired dentist from Billings got a piece of elk antler that a porcupine had gnawed. Kyle Nordquist got a lodgepole cone.

It was small and brown and hard as a stone, shut tight, glazed with old resin. He turned it over in his hand.

It's waiting for something, Ardis said. *Carry it around until you know what.*

Kyle was twenty-four and from Brainerd, Minnesota. He had done one year at the Lutheran seminary in St. Paul and quit in May, because for two years before that he had prayed every morning and every night and something that used to be on the other end of it was not there anymore, and he could not see standing up in a pulpit in that condition. His mother told people he was taking a year. He had taken a job talking to tourists about bison.

That last night Ardis read them something in a meeting room at Mammoth, with the folding chairs in rows and the lights half off. It was from John Muir, about a pine in the Sierra that was a cousin to the lodgepoles outside. She read it the way she said everything, without any extra in her voice.

> *During the calm season of Indian summer the fire creeps quietly along the ground, feeding on the needles and cones; arriving at the foot of a tree, the resiny bark is ignited and the heated air ascends in a swift current, increasing in velocity and dragging the flames upward.*
>
> *— John Muir, The Yosemite, ch. 6*

Then she closed the book and said goodnight, and everybody went up the stairs into the long June dusk with their feathers and rocks.

II. Smoke

Madison Junction · July and August

They posted him at Madison, where the Firehole and the Gibbon come together, to give the evening program at the amphitheater and rove the campground in the day. Every morning before his shift he sat on a log by the river with the cone in his hand, the way he used to sit with a Bible open on his knee, and waited for it to tell him what it was waiting for.

It did not tell him anything. It was a pinecone. He knew what it was waiting for, in the sense that he had read it on a sign. That was not what she meant, and he knew that too, and the knowing did not go anywhere. It was the same as the praying. He would sit, and the river would go by, and his mind would go off after a girl at the Old Faithful Inn, or his father's face when he told him about the seminary, or what he was going to say about bison that night, and he would bring it back to the cone, and it would go off again.

It was the driest summer anyone in the park could remember. The fires had started in June, lightning fires, and by the park's policy they

were allowed to burn, as they had been since the early seventies, because the forest had burned before there were rangers and would burn after. In the middle of July the policy was suspended and everything was ordered fought. By then it was too late to matter much. On July 22 a fire started by accident just past the west boundary, and the smoke came over Madison every afternoon after that, yellow and then brown, and the sun went down red as a stoplight.

At the amphitheater people stood up during his program and asked him why the Park Service was letting Yellowstone burn down. A man from Ohio told him he was a disgrace to the uniform. Kyle said what he had been told to say, about fire ecology, and the cones, and he did not believe a word of it, because it was not his.

In the middle of August he called Ardis from the pay phone at the Madison station. He said he thought he'd been given the wrong thing. Maybe he could have the elk, or the night sky, or something that moved. He said he had sat with the cone for two months and nothing had happened.

There was a long pause on the line. *Come up to Mammoth on your day off,* she said. *We'll find you something else.*

III. The Road

Between Madison and Norris · August 20, 1988

His day off was a Saturday. He started north at noon in his Datsun with the cone in his shirt pocket, and by the time he was past the Gibbon Falls the wind was blowing so hard it rocked the car on its springs, and the sky over the plateau to the west had gone the color of a bruise. Later they called it Black Saturday. The fires in and around the park doubled in a single afternoon.

A ranger in a yellow shirt had a sawhorse across the road at a pullout and was turning everyone back. Kyle parked. He did not turn back. He walked up a little rise of rock above the road to see.

Below him the fire was coming through the lodgepoles toward the river, and it was the thing Ardis had read to them in June. It came along

the ground first, low and quick and almost quiet under the roar of the wind, eating the needles and the cones and the dead twigs, every one of them, the way a hand goes along a row. When it reached the foot of a tree it climbed, and the whole tree went up at once in a column of flame twice its height, with a sound like a sheet shaken out, and then it was gone, and the next tree went, and the next. Small and large, it made no difference to it. It did not skip the twigs to get to the trees. It did not stop at the trees because they were big. It went on.

He stood there with the heat on his face. He thought of all the mornings on the log, and of what his mind had gone after every morning instead of the cone: the girl at the inn and his father and the man from Ohio and the seminary and the wrong thing he had been given, which he had wanted to trade for a better one. Small and large. He had been carrying all of it, choosing among it, setting some down and keeping the rest.

He looked, and kept looking, and did not choose. Whatever came up he let the looking go along it, the way the fire went along the ground, and it went. He thought of his father, and it went. He thought, this is it, and that went.

He put his hand on his pocket. The cone was warm from his body and from the air. On a burned branch at his feet, three cones from the tree above had come down hot, and while he watched, one of them opened, scale by scale, with a small ticking sound he could hear even in that wind.

When he looked up, Ardis was standing on the road below him in her flat hat.

There was no car. She was on the yellow line beyond the sawhorse with the burning trees behind her, and the light was all around her and on her, as if it came out of her and not the fire. The ranger at the barricade did not turn his head. Kyle said later that she did not shout, and that he heard her anyway.

Small and large, she said. *It doesn't pick.*

Then the smoke came across the road, and when it cleared there was the sawhorse and the ranger and nothing else.

IV. Mammoth

That evening

The seasonals tell the rest at the amphitheater, after the visitors have gone. The road north of the sawhorse was closed the rest of that day. The ranger who held it swore nobody went past him, on foot or otherwise, and Kyle's Datsun sat on the pullout for two days under a quarter inch of ash. All the same, at a little after six that evening he knocked on the door of Ardis Hollister's trailer at Mammoth, thirty miles away, with no soot on his shoes.

She opened the door in her socks. She was not surprised to see him, or did not act it. She had been home all afternoon, she said, listening to the radio.

He took the cone out of his pocket and held it out to her. It was open, every scale standing back from the core like a little tree.

She took it and tapped it on the doorframe, and the seeds came out into her hand, four or five of them, each one with its thin brown wing.

Well, she said.

He did not ask for the elk.

• • •

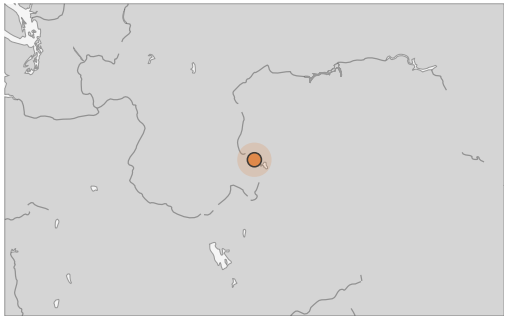
Snow fell on September 11, a quarter inch, and the fires lay down. That winter people said Yellowstone was ruined. In July of 1989, which was her last summer, Ardis drove Kyle and the new seasonals out to the burn above Madison and had them kneel in the black and count the seedlings inside a square ten paces on a side that she marked off with four tent stakes and a string. They counted a little over two hundred, each one a green tuft no bigger than a thumbnail, in rows along the fallen logs where the cones had dropped. Kyle counted his twice. He came back and gave the evening program at the amphitheater for eleven more summers, and when people asked him about the fire he told them to go out and look.

Background

The verse

> *A Bhikshu (mendicant) who delights in earnestness, who looks with fear on thoughtlessness, moves about like fire, burning all his fetters, small or large.*
>
> Dhammapada 31, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk takes a meditation subject from the Buddha at Jetavana and goes off to practice it, but makes no progress. He sets out to go back and ask for a subject better suited to him. On the way he sees a forest fire and climbs a hill to watch it, and he thinks: as this fire goes on burning everything, large and small, so should I go on, burning away every fetter with the fire of knowledge. The Buddha, sitting in his chamber, knows his thought and sends an image of himself that seems to sit before the monk, radiant, and speaks the verse. The monk reaches awakening on the spot, travels through the air to the Buddha, praises him, and goes. Read the full commentary story.



Yellowstone National Park, Wyoming

Yellowstone, 1988

From 1972 Yellowstone let most lightning-caused fires burn as part of the natural order, and in 1988, in what became the worst drought in the park's recorded history, fires that began in June spread under that policy until it was suspended on July 15. The North Fork fire, which started accidentally on July 22, burned more than 410,000 acres by itself. On August 20, remembered as Black Saturday, the fires roughly doubled in a single day; on September 7 a fire storm reached Old Faithful; and on September 11 about a quarter inch of snow stopped their advance. In all some 793,880 acres, about 36 percent of the park, burned (National Park Service; Wikipedia).

Many lodgepole pines carry serotinous cones, sealed with resin and held on the tree for years, which open in the heat of a fire. After 1988, surveys found between 15,000 and two million seeds per acre on the burned ground, and a year later between 2,000 and 12,000 seedlings per acre (NPR). Ardis reads from John Muir's *The Yosemite* (1912), chapter 6, "The Forest Trees in General," where Muir describes fire in the Sierra's two-leaved pine, a variety of the same species. The people in the story are fictional.

After the story of a certain bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 31). The original. Words from John Muir, *The Yosemite* (1912). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

2.9

Salt Tea

Long years we have enjoyed the luscious fruit it bare,
And tho' it now has none, it still should claim our care.
— Jātaka 430, tr. H. T. Francis and R. A. Neil (1897)

Thus I heard it, on the sand roads off Route 9.

I. The Round

Freewood Acres, Howell Township, New Jersey · September 1957

Gelung Sanji ate once a day, before noon, and he ate it in Freewood Acres. He had done so for five years, and in that time he had not once eaten his meal anywhere else.

Freewood Acres was a few streets of small houses laid out on sand among scrub pine, on both sides of U.S. 9, which was one lane each way then, with egg farms beyond in every direction. There were Russians there already. The Kalmyks came in the winter of 1951 and 1952, off the transports from the camps around Munich, after the Attorney General in Washington had been persuaded that a Mongol people who had lived three hundred years on the Volga and the Don could be let in as Europeans. Most of the ones in Freewood Acres were Astrakhan people, who had come out of Russia in the war. A few houses at the east end belonged to Don Kalmyks, the old emigration, who had left in 1920 with the White army and spent twenty-four years in Belgrade. Sanji's mother lived in one of those houses. His mother's brother had the next, and a cousin the one after that, and across the road lived a widow named Kermen who had known him since he was baptized, as she put it, because she had lived so long among Serbs that she used their word.

The men built houses for contractors or worked at the rug mill in Freehold. The women sewed. On the lot behind the cousin's house they had put up a cinder-block room with a stovepipe and an altar, and that was the khurul for the east end. Sanji had a cot behind a curtain at the back of it. He was thirty years old. The other monks who had come over were old men, seventy and more, ordained on the steppe under the Tsar. Sanji had been a boy in the children's choir at the temple in Belgrade, the one with the pagoda roof on the street the Serbs named Budistička. He was a novice at fourteen, and seventeen when the community walked out of Belgrade ahead of the Red Army. He had taken his full vows in a barracks in Bavaria from three old lamas who did not expect to live to ordain anyone else.

He owned the robes, a rosary, four books, and a bowl. The bowl was birch root, turned on a lathe in Belgrade by a Kalmyk carter who made them in the winters, and the Baksha had put it into his hands the day he became a novice. It had cracked in the camp, in the cold of 1946, and a Latvian in the next barracks had closed the crack with a brass staple. A monk of his people carries his own bowl in the fold of his robe and holds it out to be filled. In six years in Bavaria it had been filled with barley soup from the kitchens of the refugee administration, and with turnips, and some days it had not been filled. He had learned in those years what he needed, and it had turned out to be less than he would have guessed.

His father had been an officer of Don Cossacks and afterward the head tailor of the colony, and in Belgrade the family had counted for something. Here his mother sewed sleeve linings for a coat factory in Lakewood, piecework, eleven cents the pair.

Every morning after the prayers Sanji folded his outer robe over his arm and went out on the sand road, and at one house or another a door opened. He never chose the house. Whoever saw him first called him in, and the woman of the house set before him the first of whatever was in the pot. That was the custom, the *deeji*, the first portion, which goes to the altar or to a monk. Most days it was Kalmyk tea, brick tea boiled in the kettle with milk and salt, with a lump of butter melting on top and a little nutmeg if there was nutmeg. With it came *bortsak*, the fried dough,

and if a sheep had been bought from a farmer that week there was *budan*, the soup, with meat in it. He ate what was set down. He took no second bowl of anything but tea. If there was meat, he ate meat, and on the days the woman of the house apologized for the pot, he ate that with the same attention and at the same speed. When he had eaten he said the blessing for the house, and he went back to the cinder-block room and did not go out again to see whether some other pot had something better in it.

The rest of the day he kept the lamps and said the offices. On Saturdays he taught nine children to read Kalmyk in the old upright script, which their parents could no longer read themselves.

II. The City

North Philadelphia · the same autumn

The larger part of the Don Kalmyks had settled in Philadelphia, fifty-five miles down the road, in the row houses north of Girard Avenue. There was steady work there in the needle trades and the cigar and candy factories. The principal temple was there, on the ground floor of a row house, and the old lamas lived above it. The head of them was the Baksha, Lidji, who was eighty-one, and who was an *emchi*, a doctor of the Tibetan medicine, which he had learned as a boy on the Don from a man who had learned it in Lhasa.

People came up the stairs to him all day. He took a wrist in three fingers and listened to it with his eyes shut, for as long as another man would take to read a letter, and then he said what was wrong and went to his jars. He had brought the jars from Belgrade through the camps wrapped in his bedding. He had lost the high lama's cushion on the way, and his books of ritual, and he said that he could manage without those. He had been Sanji's teacher from the day the boy was brought to the temple school at seven. He was not a talker. In twenty-three years Sanji had heard him say perhaps four things that were not about medicine or the order of a service, and remembered all four.

The Americans had found the Kalmyks in Philadelphia. The Friends had helped bring them over and did not forget them, and a professor

from the University came with a tape recorder. And there was Mrs. Thayer.

Mrs. Thayer was a widow with a house in Chestnut Hill. In 1924 she had gone with her husband to Peking and Kalgan and out onto the Mongolian plateau on a camel, and nothing in her life before or since had come up to it. When she read in the *Bulletin* that there were Mongol lamas living on North Tenth Street, she drove there the same afternoon. After that the gifts did not stop. She bought every monk new robes of real Chinese brocade from a dealer in New York. She gave the temple an oil furnace and a refrigerator, and a Buick for the lamas to be driven in. At the New Year and at each of the great days there was an envelope for each monk with a hundred-dollar bill in it. And on feast days she sent a caterer's truck to North Tenth Street with whole roasted lambs, and rice, and oranges in crates, and five kinds of cake, and came herself and sat on a cushion among the old women and was entirely happy. The Kalmyks, who had seen charity of several kinds in several countries, agreed that this was a kind they had not seen. They called her the Khatun, the queen, without much mockery in it.

The old monks went to her table in their brocade. They sent word to Freewood Acres each time, and each time Sanji sent back his respects and stayed where he was.

It began to be talked of. Gelung Dordji said it first, and then they all said it. *The young one is busy enough up there. He sits in his mother's kitchen like a schoolboy home for dinner. It's his uncle today and his cousin tomorrow. A monk leaves his family, and this one has found a way to leave them and keep them. The Khatun asks for him every time, a monk who can read, a young man, and he can't come fifty miles. What is it he has up there that is better than his own teachers' company?*

They said it finally to the Baksha, who was grinding something in a mortar and did not stop.

III. Three Bowls

Freewood Acres · October and November

That autumn the work went. The whole country slid into a recession, and the rug mill in Freehold cut to four days and then to three and let the newest hands go, and the newest hands were Kalmyks. The contractors stopped starting houses. The egg farmers, who had been getting poorer for three years, quit buying anything. In the east end of Freewood Acres four families of the old emigration packed and went to Philadelphia, where a cousin could speak for them at the candy factory, and their houses stood with paper over the windows.

Sanji went out on the sand road every morning as before, and what was in the pots changed.

There had been no budan since September. First the butter went out of the tea, and after that the nutmeg. By November his mother's tea had milk in it only because she gave him the milk and drank her own black. He saw that and said nothing, since there was nothing to say that would not shame her. He ate her bortsak, which was made now with oil saved from the last frying, and told her it was the bortsak of Belgrade.

On a morning in the middle of November it was the widow Kermen who opened her door. She was seventy-four and lived alone on what a son sent from Philadelphia when he had it. He set his bowl on her table. She brought the kettle and poured, and what came out of it was brick tea and salt and water. She had no milk. She set a plate beside the bowl with two bortsak on it from some earlier day. They were hard enough to knock on.

She stood by the stove with her back to him, and he saw that her shoulders were moving.

Emgen, he said, which is grandmother. *Sit down. Is there more in the kettle?*

There's nothing in the kettle. It's water.

It's tea. Pour me another.

He drank three bowls, slowly, and he soaked the bortsak in the third until it could be eaten and ate both. Then he said the blessing for her house, the long one, all of it. She said afterward that he drank that salt

water as if it were the tea of a khan's tent, and that she had looked hard at his face for the politeness in it and had not found any. He had sat there like a man who had what he wanted.

That same week the Buick came up Route 9 with Gelung Dordji in the back seat. There was to be a dinner at Chestnut Hill. Dordji stood in the cinder-block room in his brocade and looked at the cot and the curtain.

There are sixty families in Philadelphia and a furnace in the temple, he said. *Here there are twenty houses and half of them can't feed themselves. What are you living on?*

I ate this morning.

What?

Tea.

Dordji went back to the city alone. The next word that came from North Tenth Street was from the Baksha, and all it said was to come.

IV. The Question

North Tenth Street · the week before Zul, December 1957

He went down on two buses with his outer robe in a paper bag, because of how people looked at it. The second bus came into the city past miles of row houses with lit windows, and stores, and a factory with its night shift going in at the gate carrying lunch pails. He looked at all of it with interest, as he would have looked at a river in flood, and he felt no wish to stay in it. The monks were all in the upper front room. The Baksha sat by the window on a kitchen chair with a blanket over his knees. He was a very small man. His hands smelled of the roots he ground.

Sanji made the three prostrations and sat on the floor.

They tell me, said the Baksha, *that you live up there in the middle of your family. That you are in and out of your mother's house and your uncle's house all day, and that this is why you never come to us, with everything that is given here. Is it so?*

No, Baksha.

The old man waited.

I go out once in the morning, Sanji said. *Somebody calls me in. Some days it is my mother and some days it is a house where I am no relation. I take from them what I can eat at that sitting. When I have had what will keep me that day, I go back and shut the door. It may be coarse or it may be fine. I have had enough, so why should I go looking for more? I am not with my relations, Baksha. I spend less of the day with my mother than Gelung Dordji spends with Mrs. Thayer.*

One of the old monks laughed and turned it into a cough.

And when the houses had nothing? the Baksha said. *This autumn.*

They never had nothing. There was tea.

The Baksha looked at him for some time. Then he said, *Good,* and after a moment he said it again. *Good.*

He turned his head toward the others. *You wonder at him. I don't wonder. He had teachers who lived that way, and I was one of them, before I got old and people began bringing me refrigerators. It is the oldest habit in this robe. It is older than the robe.*

Gelung Dordji, who was an honest man and already ashamed, asked him to say how it was older than the robe. So the Baksha told it. He told it in Kalmyk, as it is told to children, with his hands lying still on the blanket.

V. The Parrot

A fig grove on the Ganges · long ago

THERE WAS A GROVE OF FIG TREES ON THE BANK OF THE RIVER Ganga, under the snow mountains, and so many parrots lived in it that when they rose the sky went green. Each had its tree. The king of the parrots had his, and he ate its figs, and drank from the river.

A year came when the figs on his tree were finished. He ate the shoots, and when those were gone he ate the leaves and then the bark. He drank from the river and sat in his tree, and he was content. He was so entirely content that up in his heaven the seat of Khormusta, the king of the gods, grew warm under him. Khormusta looked down to see who on earth had that much merit. He saw a green bird in a bare tree.

Khormusta thought he would see how deep it went, and he dried the tree. It died where it stood. It became a grey stump full of holes, and when the wind blew, the stump moaned and dust came out of the holes. The other birds had long since gone to trees with fruit on them. The parrot ate the dust. He drank from the river and sat on top of the stump in the wind and the sun, and he went nowhere.

Then Khormusta took the shape of a wild goose and came down with his queen and perched on a branch nearby. *Bird,* he said, *there are green trees up and down this river, heavy with figs. I have just flown over them. Why do you sit on a dead stump eating dust?*

And the parrot said:

> *Long years we have enjoyed the luscious fruit it bare,*
> *And tho' it now has none, it still should claim our care.*
>
> *— Jātaka 430, tr. H. T. Francis and R. A. Neil (1897)*

The others left, the goose said. *Were they wrong? There is nothing here.*

They loved it for its figs, said the parrot. *I ate its figs as long as any of them did. Now it has dust, and I find I can live on that. Why would I go?*

Then the goose was a goose no longer, and the parrot saw who had been speaking with him. *Ask me for something,* Khormusta said. *Whatever you want most.*

The parrot might have asked for any tree on the river, or for a heaven. He said, *Let me see this one in leaf again.*

Khormusta took up water from the Ganga in his hand and threw it over the stump. The tree stood up green from the root, with shade under it, and its figs were sweet as honey. He went back to his heaven. The parrot stayed in the tree.

• • •

That bird was our Teacher, Burkhan Bagshi, the Baksha said, *before he was a man, when he was only on the way. So you see where the habit comes from. Anyone will stay for figs. To stay for the tree, he has to be awake to what he is*

doing every day, and afraid of the day he stops. A monk like that doesn't fall. There isn't far for him to go.

Nobody in the room spoke. Half the men there had been born on the Don and had seen their villages emptied, and the rest had come from the Volga, where in the last week of 1943 the whole Kalmyk nation was put on cattle trains for Siberia in four days and its name was taken off the map. In January of that year the Russian paper from New York had carried four lines saying that the name had been put back. None of them knew what to make of that, and each of them was thinking of it.

VI. Zul

Philadelphia and Freewood Acres · the middle of December

THEY KEPT HIM FOR ZUL, THE FEAST OF LAMPS, WHEN EVERY Kalmyk becomes a year older on the same night. The women had kneaded dough and shaped it into small boats, and in each boat they set wicks of grass stalk wound with cotton, one for each year of the person's age and one over, and filled it with melted butter. When it was dark the lamps were lit and carried up and set before the altar. There were more than a hundred of them. Mrs. Thayer's lambs had come that afternoon. She sat among the old women holding a dough lamp with sixty-eight wicks, which she had counted out herself.

The Baksha was helped down the stairs. He did not go to the high seat. He stopped in front of Sanji, who was at the end of the row of monks, in his cotton robe among the brocade. He said a verse over him in Tibetan, and then in Kalmyk, slowly, so that the people behind could hear it. It is in the book of the Teacher's sayings that the Kalmyks have from the Tibetans, who have kept it a thousand years.

> *The Bhixu who delights in purity and who looks with dread on impurity is so near nirvana that he cannot fail (to reach it).*
>
> *— Udānavarga 4:30, tr. W. W. Rockhill (1883)*

The word they have put as purity means taking care, the Baksha said. *It is how a man carries a full bowl.*

Sanji had heard that verse since he was a boy in the choir in Belgrade. He had sung it. Standing in the row with a hundred lamps in front of him, he heard it as a thing said about a particular morning, the morning of the salt tea, when he had looked into the bowl and found nothing in himself that wanted it to be otherwise. He had not known then that there was anything to notice. He saw now that the wanting had gone out of him some time ago without his marking the day. No dinner in Chestnut Hill could bring it back, and no empty kettle could either. He stood very still. The old monks said afterward that his face in the lamplight was like the face of a man who has set down a load at his own door. Gelung Dordji, beside him, took off his brocade outer robe and folded it and laid it on the floor, and stood the rest of the night in the cotton one underneath.

Mrs. Thayer asked to have the young lama presented to her. He came and thanked her for the furnace, which kept old men warm, and he ate at her feast exactly what he would have eaten in his mother's kitchen. He took a piece of lamb, because it was put before him, and bortsak, and tea. In the morning he went north on the two buses.

• • •

He lived in the cinder-block room for thirty-one years more. The mill went back to five days in the spring and then, some years later, shut for good, and the east end found other work, as it always had. Nobody else from those houses moved to the city. The old women said you could not leave a place that a monk like that would not leave, and they said it as a complaint.

The morning he came back from Philadelphia it was snowing a little on the sand road. The first door that opened was the widow Kermen's. She had milk that week, her son having sent five dollars, and she had been to the store for butter and stood now with the kettle in her hand, and she watched his face as she poured to see what it would do.

It did what it had done in November. He held out the bowl with the brass staple in it, and she filled it, and he lifted it in both hands and drank.

Background

The verse

> *A Bhikshu (mendicant) who delights in reflection, who looks with fear on thoughtlessness, cannot fall away (from his perfect state)—he is close upon Nirvana.*
>
> Dhammapada 32, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young man of good family from a market town near Sāvatthī becomes a monk and is known as Tissa of the Market Town. He goes for alms only in the village where his relatives live and never comes to the city, though the great donors there are giving lavishly. The monks complain that he lives entangled with his kin. Questioned by the Buddha, Tissa says he takes from them only what he needs to eat, coarse or fine, and seeks nothing more. The Buddha applauds him, says that contentment was his own habit too, and tells the birth story of the parrot king who would not leave his fig tree even when the god Sakka withered it to dust, and who asked, when offered any gift, only to see the tree in leaf again. Then he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story. The parrot's couplet here comes from the 1897 Cambridge translation of the Jātaka; the verse the Baksha recites is the same Dhammapada verse as it stands in the Udānavarga, the collection preserved in the Tibetan canon that Kalmyk and Mongolian Buddhists inherited, in W. W. Rockhill's 1883 translation from the Tibetan.

Freewood Acres, New Jersey

Freewood Acres, 1957

The Kalmyks are a western Mongol people, Tibetan Buddhists, who have lived on the lower Volga and the Don since the seventeenth century. Some hundreds left Russia with the defeated White armies in 1920 and settled in the Balkans; in Belgrade they built a temple in 1929, one of the first Buddhist temples in Europe, and left it in 1944. Others came west during the war. On December 28–31, 1943, the Soviet government deported the entire Kalmyk population, more than 93,000 people, to Siberia and abolished their republic; a Kalmyk Autonomous Oblast was re-established by decree on January 9, 1957. The Kalmyks stranded in displaced persons camps near Munich were at first barred from the United States as Asians. In 1951 the Attorney General's office ruled them admissible, and most arrived between December 1951 and April 1952, sponsored by the Tolstoy Foundation, Church World Service and the Society of Friends.

They settled mainly in north-central Philadelphia and in Freewood Acres, on U.S. Route 9 in Howell Township, New Jersey, where their temples still stand. Fred Adelman's 1961 article "The American Kalmyks" describes the two colonies, the Philadelphia factory jobs, the New Jersey men's work in housing construction and "until the recent recession, a carpet factory," the butter tea, the fried *bortsak* and the *budan* soup, and a senior monk who was a doctor of Tibetan medicine. The recession of 1957–58 is the one in this story. Zul, the lamp festival in early winter, is the Kalmyk new year of age. Sanji, the Baksha, Mrs. Thayer and the temple on North Tenth Street are invented, and the east-end khurul is not any of the real Howell temples.

After the story of the Elder Nigamavāsī Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 32). The original. Scripture from the Udānavarga, translated from the Tibetan by W. W. Rockhill (1883), and the Jātaka, vol. 3, translated by H. T. Francis and R. A. Neil (1897). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 3

Thought

3.1

Julie Mango

> *For, O Krishna! the mind is fickle, boisterous, strong, and obstinate; and I think that to restrain it is as difficult as (to restrain) the wind.*
> *— Bhagavadgîtâ 6:34*

Is so I hear it, in the Redland.

I. Five Leaves

The Redland, south Miami-Dade County, Florida · June 2019

The Boodrams had a house and five acres off Krome Avenue, down where the county quits being city and goes to nurseries and avocado and mango, and for nine nights that June they were holding a Ramayan yagna in the yard. They had put up a rented tent with the sides rolled, and two hundred folding chairs, and a low stage with a white sheet over it and a cushion for the reader. Along the fence, nine new jhandi flags stood on bamboo poles. Every evening at six the cars came down from Broward, from Lauderhill and Miramar and Pembroke Pines, where the Trinidadians and Guyanese mostly lived, and people sat until ten hearing the Ramayan of Tulsidas sung and explained, and ate curry off paper plates afterward, and drove an hour home.

The reader was Pandita Chandra Maharaj. She was sixty-six. She had been born in Felicity, in central Trinidad, where her father made the bows and arrows for the village Ramleela every year, and she had come to Florida in 1984 and worked twenty-six years doing the books for a tile importer in Hialeah. When her husband died she went back to what she had learned sitting under her father's elbow. She studied for six years, and a mandir off State Road 7 installed her, and some of the old men

stopped coming, and after a while came back. She read well. She did not embroider, and she spoke little outside the reading. People drove an hour for that.

She had one habit that people remarked on. When somebody came to her with a trouble, a son on pills or a husband gone quiet or a business going under, she did not answer straight off. She went on with whatever was in her hands until it was done. Then she said one thing, and it was generally short enough to remember in the car.

She stayed in the Boodrams' back bedroom for the nine days, because a reader does not go and come. In the daytime the house was empty. Mr. Boodram and his wife and both sons were at their nursery in Homestead from six in the morning, and nobody else came before five, when her sister-in-law Shanta drove down with the singers.

So in the daytime there was the Pandita, and there was Kavi.

Kavish Ramnarine was twenty-two. He had been born at Broward General and raised in Lauderhill, and he had left Broward College after three semesters and been let go by a warehouse in Opa-locka. He delivered food in his mother's Corolla. Fourteen months ago the Pandita had done the thirteen days' work for his grandfather, and on the thirteenth day he had asked if he could carry her harmonium to the car. He had been carrying it since. He drove her and set up the bedi. He knew which brass went where. He had stopped eating meat and had stopped a few other things too, or was trying, and he watched a great many videos about meditation. He had tried it in his bedroom at five in the morning with the door shut, and in the Corolla between orders, parked behind a Wendy's with the seat back. He could manage three or four minutes. Then his mother ran the blender, or the phone lit up, or a truck backed in, and he put it down to the place. He was sure that something large was about to happen to him if he could only get the conditions right.

On the sixth morning she sent him to the Publix on Krome for milk and ghee, and told him to bring back five mango leaves for the kalash, clean ones with no spot on them. The Boodrams grew palms and crotons and did not own a mango tree.

He bought the milk and the ghee. Coming back he left the car at the corner and walked in along the canal, since a canal bank in the Redland is as good a place as any to find a mango tree. The bank road was white limestone, and it was hot. The water was green and perfectly clear, and he could see fish hanging in it over the weed.

A quarter mile in, on the far side of a culvert, he came to the grove.

It was an old one. The trees had been planted forty feet apart sixty or seventy years ago, and nobody had topped them, so that they met overhead, and underneath it was a green room the size of a city block with a floor of dry leaves. The light came down in coins. It was ten degrees cooler inside the first row. Fruit hung everywhere on long stems. Most of it was the big red commercial kinds, but along the canal side stood a row of low, dense, round-headed trees with small flattened fruit going from green to rose, and he knew those. His grandfather had had one in a tub behind the house in Lauderhill and had babied it for twenty years against the fungus. They were Julies. An old man in a straw hat was sitting on an overturned crate by a pump house. He said in Spanish and then in English that the grove was sold and would be houses by next year, and that Kavi could take what he wanted, leaves, mangoes, anything, it was all the same to him. His father had planted the Julies for a Jamaican foreman in 1958, he said. There was nothing wrong with them except that nobody would pay for a mango that small.

Kavi picked five leaves. He stood a minute longer in the green shade. It was so quiet in there that he could hear a mango let go somewhere and come down through the leaves. He thought that this was a place a person could really sit. He had been looking for it for a year, in his bedroom with the door shut and in the Corolla in parking lots, and it had been here the whole time.

II. Three Times

The Boodrams' kitchen · eleven o'clock

The Pandita was at the stove with a bundle of bamboo garden stakes from the Home Depot. The mandir's children did Ramleela

EVERY OCTOBER, AND EVERY SUMMER SHE MADE THE ARROWS, forty of them, because there was nobody else who knew how. She took the five leaves and looked at each one and nodded.

Panditaji, he said. *There's a mango grove down the canal. An old one. Nobody's in there. It's the kind of place the rishis sat. I want to go and sit there today. Do my sadhana properly, the whole afternoon, till it's time. I think I need that.*

She turned a stake over the gas flame.

Wait, she said. *I alone here today. Wait till somebody else reach.*

Shanta Aunty's coming at five.

So wait till five.

He washed the leaves and set them in the brass lota around a dry coconut, and he swept the stage. At half past eleven he came back to the kitchen door.

Panditaji, you have everything here. You finished what you had to do. I haven't finished anything. I don't see how I'm going to get anywhere carrying a harmonium. I'd like to go to that grove.

I alone here, Kavi. Wait.

He went out and wiped down two hundred chairs that did not need it. At noon he came back a third time and said it again, and this time he said it with his hands together.

She laid the stake down. She looked at him the way she looked at a leaf.

When a boy say he want to go and strive, what I could tell him? she said. *I can't tell him no. Do what you think it is time to do.*

He touched her feet, quickly, and was out of the yard before she had picked up the stake again. He left his phone in the car on purpose.

III. The Grove

Under the Julie trees · the afternoon

HE CHOSE THE FOURTH JULIE FROM THE CULVERT BECAUSE ITS roots made a seat. He folded his legs and set his back straight the way the

VIDEOS SAID, WITH HIS HANDS IN HIS LAP. HE SHUT HIS EYES and began to say the name of Ram with his breath.

He had perhaps four minutes of it.

Then, without any decision on his part, he was thinking about Reshma Singh. She sang in the youth group. At Phagwah in March she had been soaked to the skin in a white kurta, pink and green with abeer, laughing with her head back. He had looked away at the time. He did not look away now. He looked for a long while, and when he had finished with what he had actually seen, his mind supplied the rest. After Reshma there were others. He had gotten rid of certain things on his phone in January, and the phone was in the car, and it made no difference at all. He had them all by heart, and here in the place of the rishis they played for him one after another, and nothing interrupted them.

He opened his eyes. He was sweating. He shut them and went back to the name.

It was his cousin Darren next. Darren had the dispatcher's job at their uncle's trucking yard, the job that had been promised to Kavi in front of the whole family at a wedding. Darren called him Baba and Swami now and asked him when he was going up the mountain. Kavi began explaining to Darren what Darren was, and once he had begun he could not stop. He went from Darren to the uncle. From the uncle he went to his own father, who had gone to Orlando with a woman from his job when Kavi was eleven and sent a card at Divali with fifty dollars in it. He said to his father, in full, with pauses for effect, what he had been composing for eleven years. It did not make him feel better. He said it again with improvements.

The afternoon went on. A wind came up in the tops of the trees and the light turned yellow. Mangoes came down around him now and then with a thump, and he could smell the ones that had split. There were small black ants on his ankle. Twice he got as far as noticing his breath, and each time it was like putting a hand flat on water.

Last was the supervisor at the warehouse in Opa-locka. He had made Kavi stand in front of the line and be told, before thirty people, that he was too slow to be worth the badge. In Kavi's mind the man was in the

parking lot beside his truck. Kavi had something in his hand, and he used it. He was thorough. He watched the man's face while he did it, and he found that he liked watching.

Something moved, and he opened his eyes. An iguana as long as his arm had come down the trunk of the next tree and stopped on a root six feet off, head up, its throat going. He had a piece of limestone in his hand. He did not remember picking it up. His arm was already back.

He put the stone down on the leaves, carefully, as if it might go off.

He sat with his hands shaking. He was a person who had given up meat. He had touched the Pandita's feet that noon, and for a year he had told himself that he was leaving the world behind, and he had come to the quietest place in South Florida to do it. All afternoon the world had sat in his lap. He had brought it in with him. He had not had ten clean breaths together.

How? he said out loud. *I came here for God. How is this what's in me?*

The first big drops came through the leaves then, and thunder off toward the Everglades, and within a minute it was raining the way it rains there on a June afternoon, straight down, as if a tank had split. He sat under it. He was not doing anything else that was any use.

IV. The Bank

The canal · after the rain

It stopped in forty minutes and the sun came out and the limestone steamed. He walked back along the canal, wet through, with six Julie mangoes in the front of his shirt, because he could not think what else to bring her.

Two boys had been fishing at the culvert before the storm and had gone. On the bank road, a yard from the water, lay a fish they had thrown there, a brown armored catfish, the kind from the aquarium trade that is in every canal now and that nobody wants on a hook. It was not dead. It lay on the hot white rock and bent itself double and sprang, and it came down in the same place. It did this again and again without any direction

to it, and its gills worked. The water was three feet away and clear as glass. It had no way of knowing that.

Kavi stood over it a long time, longer than made sense. Then he put the side of his shoe under it and flipped it into the canal. It hung in the water where it fell for a second or two, then went down into the weed.

When he came into the Boodrams' yard he saw what the storm had done. The wind had got under the tent on the south side and torn four stakes out, and that whole wall of canvas was down across the chairs. The white sheet on the stage was grey with wet. The harmonium was not on the stage. Neither was the book stand, or the Ramayan in its red cloth, or the brass.

They were in the kitchen, dry, on the table. The Pandita was sitting beside them with her left leg out straight on a second chair and a bag of frozen peas on the hip. It was the hip the surgeon had done in November. Her sari was wet to the waist. The harmonium weighed thirty-one pounds; he had weighed it once.

V. The Arrow

The kitchen · four o'clock

He put the mangoes on the counter. He did not sit down.

Tell me, she said.

He told her. He was twenty-two and it was not easy to say to a woman of sixty-six, a pandita, what had gone through him under that tree, and he said it anyway. He told her about the girl and the others, and about Darren and his father, and about the man in the parking lot. He told her about the stone in his hand. *I went there out of faith,* he said. *I swear I did. And that is all that came. Those three things, round and round. I don't understand it.*

She heard all of it without moving her face.

You do a wrong thing today, she said. *I not vex. But hear it. I tell you wait, I alone. Three times. And you went your way. When I ask you to stay, you must not leave me alone and go. I am not saying it for the hip.* She lifted the peas

and set them down again. *You went because the mind say go. The mind see a pretty place and it start to jump, and you follow it out the gate like a man following a goat. Then you sit down in the pretty place and you surprise that it still jumping. Is the same mind, child. You carry it there.*

She pulled the bundle of bamboo toward her across the table and drew one stake out.

Look down this.

He sighted along it. It wandered left, and then right, and it had a hook at the tip.

In Felicity my father used cane arrow, the flower stalk of the cane. He would cut two hundred after crop and lose half. Same thing. Nothing does grow straight. If you shoot that, it going in the neighbor yard. She lit the burner and held the stake above the flame at its worst bend, turning it, until the skin of the bamboo began to sweat. She took it off and bent it against the curve with both thumbs and held it there while it cooled, and put it to her eye. She put it back to the fire at another place. She did this five times. It took as long as it took. Then she handed it to him and he looked down it, and it ran dead true from his eye to the far wall.

He had watched her make thirty of these that week and had taken it for a thing old people did with their hands. He had not once looked down one.

It will take the bend again, if you leave it in the damp, she said. *So you do it again. That is all the work is. Arjuna tell Krishna the same thing you tell me. He was a better archer than you.*

> *For, O Krishna! the mind is fickle, boisterous, strong, and obstinate;*
> *and I think that to restrain it is as difficult as (to restrain) the wind.*
>
> *The Deity said: Doubtless, O you of mighty arms! the mind is difficult to restrain, and fickle. Still, O son of Kuntî! it may be restrained by constant practice and by indifference (to worldly objects).*
>
> *— Bhagavadgîtâ 6:34–35, tr. K. T. Telang (1882)*

Constant practice, she said. *He didn't say a nice grove.*

Kavi stood holding the arrow.

There was a fish, he said. *On the canal bank. Some boys threw it up on the rock. It kept jumping. It couldn't—*

Yes, said the Pandita. *That is it exactly. Tulsidas say so in the first book. You will hear it tonight.*

VI. The Sixth Night

The Boodrams' yard · evening

SHANTA CAME AT FIVE WITH THE SINGERS AND FOUND KAVI and the Boodram sons driving tent stakes. By six the wall was up and the sheet had been changed, and the cars were turning in off Krome Avenue. He carried the harmonium out and set it on the stage, and then the book stand and the book, and went back for her. She came across the yard on his arm, slowly, in a dry sari, and nobody watching would have known about the hip. Mrs. Boodram had come home to a wet yard and a wet reader and had started to cry, and the Pandita had told her to go and see about the pumpkin.

She read that night from the first book, out of her order, and she made no remark on it. She sang the doha once in the Avadhi, to the old tune, with Shanta on the dholak, and then gave it in English out of the worn green Growse she had from her father, who had it from a schoolmaster in Chaguanas.

> *Free from sensual passions and absorbed in devout affection to Ráma, the soul disports itself like a fish in the ambrosial lake of his beloved name.*
>
> *— Rámáyana of Tulsi Dás, Childhood, dohá 26, tr. F. S. Growse*

The Englishman put soul, she told the two hundred chairs. *Tulsidas put* man. *The mind. He say the mind is a fish. Now a fish is a quick thing and a strong thing, and where it belong, it is beautiful. Take it out and throw it on the bank and you will see something else. It flap. It jump this side and that side, and you would swear is wickedness, but it only frighten and dry. It doesn't want a prettier bank. It want the water.* She looked down the tent, over all of them,

and her eye did not stop on the back row. *And you can't throw yourself in. Somebody have to stand near you. So when your guru say wait, wait.*

That was all she said about it. She went on with the reading.

Kavi sat at the back by the tent pole with the dhantal across his knees, the long steel rod and its striker, keeping the time for the singers. He kept it through the whole of that night's singing and did not once come in late. He noticed, somewhere in the second hour, that he had not been anywhere else. Reshma Singh was thirty feet away in the third row and he knew it, the way he knew where the tent pole was. Darren was not there. The man in the parking lot had gone back to being a man he had worked for once. The thoughts still came up, and each time he felt the pull of it and did not go. He did not feel holy. He felt like the stake when it came off the fire, sore along one side, and for the moment straight.

He went on driving her and carrying the harmonium, and he did not ask again to be let off. He went back to the grove only once. The next year he drove down Krome to see it, and it was a field of white limestone fill with survey stakes in rows and one sales trailer. Past the culvert the canal was the same, green and clear, with the fish hanging in it over the weed.

But that was later. On the sixth night, after the arti, when the plates had gone round and the cars were pulling out, he found her at the kitchen table with a knife and the six Julies. She had cut the cheeks off the first one and scored them. She pushed one across to him on the flat of the blade.

You pick these?

Yes, Panditaji.

Then something good come out of that place, she said, and bit into her half.

Background

The verses

> *As a fletcher makes straight his arrow, a wise man makes straight his trembling and unsteady thought, which is difficult to guard, difficult to hold back.*
>
> Dhammapada 33, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *As a fish taken from his watery home and thrown on dry ground, our thought trembles all over in order to escape the dominion of Mara (the tempter).*
>
> Dhammapada 34, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary refers to the old discourse about Meghiya (Udāna 4.1), who was for a time the Buddha's attendant. Coming back from his alms round along a riverbank, Meghiya sees a lovely mango grove and asks leave to go and meditate there. The Buddha says: wait, I am alone, until another monk comes. Meghiya asks a second and a third time, and the Buddha answers that when a man speaks of striving there is nothing to say, and he should do what he thinks it is time for. Meghiya sits all day at the root of a tree and is overrun by three kinds of thought, of sensual pleasure, of ill will and of cruelty, and is astonished that he, who left home out of faith, should be so caught. In the evening he goes back and tells it. The Buddha reproves him for leaving when he was asked to stay, tells him the mind is flighty and must be kept in hand, and speaks the two verses. Read the full commentary story.

The Redland, Florida

South Florida, 2019

Between 1838 and 1917 the British shipped several hundred thousand indentured laborers from north India to the sugar estates of Trinidad and British Guiana. Their descendants, the Indo-Caribbean people, kept a Hinduism centered on the *Ramcharitmanas*, the Ramayan that Tulsidas composed in Avadhi in the sixteenth century: yard flags on bamboo poles (*jhandi*), multi-night household readings called yagnas,

and the open-air Ramleela plays, for which central Trinidad villages such as Felicity are known. From the 1960s on many families moved again, to New York, Toronto and South Florida, where Broward County towns like Lauderhill and Miramar have large Trinidadian and Guyanese communities and many mandirs. Pandits were by custom Brahmin men; women began to be installed as pandits in Trinidad in the 1990s, and the question is still argued. The Pandita reads from the English prose version by F. S. Growse, a British magistrate in India, first published in parts beginning in 1877; her gloss on the doha is fair to the original, where it is the mind (*man*) that the devotees make a fish in that lake.

The Redland is the farming district of southern Miami-Dade County, named for its pockets of red clay over limestone, and it has grown mangoes commercially for generations. The Julie, a small, flattened, richly flavored mango on a dwarf tree, is the favorite of Jamaica and Trinidad and is grown in Florida mostly by Caribbean families in their yards, since it suffers from fungus in the humid summers. Old groves in the Redland have been giving way to housing for decades. The drainage canals of South Florida are full of introduced fish, among them the South American armored catfish released from aquariums. The people, the yagna and the grove in this story are invented.

After the story of the Elder Meghiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 33 and 34). The original. Scripture from the Bhagavadgîtâ, translated by Kâshinâth Trimbak Telang (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 8, 1882), and the Rámáyana of Tulsi Dás, translated by F. S. Growse. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

3.2

The Dinner Bell

Sobre toda cosa guardada guarda tu corazón; porque de él mana la vida.
— Proverbios 4:23

Así me lo contaron, on the Verde below Cottonwood.

I. The Bend

Verde River below Cottonwood, Arizona · June 2021

They came up from Phoenix the week the heat broke the records down there, when it was a hundred and eighteen at the airport on a Thursday and the radio said not to touch the seat belt buckle. There were sixty of them. They came in Subarus, pickups, a Prius with a cracked windshield, and one old school bus painted the color of a cantaloupe. At the Circle K on Main Street they asked the man buying ice where a person could stay cheap for the summer, near water, where nobody would bother them.

The man buying ice was Matt Matkovich. Matt ran the volunteer fire company on that stretch of the river, sat on the ditch board, and knew whose well was going dry and whose cows were on whose lease. People called him the mayor of the river road, though the river road was not a town and had never had a mayor. He looked at the bus. He said they had better talk to his mother.

Dora Matkovich was seventy-five. She had been born in Jerome in 1946, up on the side of Cleopatra Hill, when the mine was still working and her father went underground every morning with his lunch in a lard can. When the mine closed in 1953 the family came down the mountain to Clarkdale, like almost everybody else, and she grew up in the smelter

town with the black slag heap along the river and married Steve Matkovich, whose grandfather had come from Dalmatia to work for the United Verde. She and Steve had built the Verde Bend RV Park out of a hayfield: sixty spaces under the cottonwoods on a bend of the river, a cinderblock bathhouse, a ramada, an office with a porch, and on a cedar post by the porch a school bell Steve had bought at a salvage sale in Prescott for nine dollars and hung there for no reason except that he liked it.

Steve had been dead four years. In summer the park was empty. Nobody wants to camp at a hundred and eight.

She came down to the office in her housedress and looked at them standing in the gravel. They were all ages. A big old man with a white beard and a Kingman Bulldogs cap. A thin Indian girl with a laptop bag. A Black man in a pressed shirt who looked like a preacher and turned out to have been one. A Mormon mother from Gilbert. Kids with tattoos. A woman in hospital scrubs, faded, who said she had quit. Dora made them sit on the porch and brought out sun tea in a pickle jar and a plate of coyotas from the panadería in Cottonwood, and when they had eaten she asked them where they were going.

Somewhere good, the old man said. *Somewhere we can sit still till the rains are over.*

She understood then what they were looking for. She looked at the sixty spaces, every one of them empty, and the cottonwoods, and the river going by low and green.

Stay here, she said. *Stay till the rains are done, and I'll charge you what the electric costs. And if you stay,* and here she surprised herself, *I'll go back to Mass. I haven't been since my husband.*

They looked at each other and said yes. Afterward some of them admitted that what they had thought was: with this woman here, we won't have to worry about anything. We can do the work.

• • •

The work was Graciela's. All sixty of them had found it the same way, alone, at night, on a phone: a woman in a parked car in a hospital garage,

still in her scrubs, the mask pulled down under her chin and the marks of it pressed into her face, saying almost nothing for one minute. She was an ICU nurse in Phoenix. In the first winter of the pandemic she had started filming herself after her shifts, before she drove home, and she had made thirty-two of the videos and then stopped. Each one was a part of the body. *Hair of the head. Nails. Teeth. Skin.* All the way down the list to the blood, the sweat, the tears, the spit. In each one she said where she had seen that part of a person the night before, and what it had looked like, and then she said the same word at the end, every time, and turned off the camera.

Prestado. Borrowed.

The sixty had found each other in the comments. In the spring they had gone down to Phoenix and waited for her on the fourth level of the parking garage at seven in the morning, when the night shift came off, and asked her how to do it for real, all day, for a whole season. She had looked at them a long time over the roof of her car. Then she had told them: go through the thirty-two. One at a time. Find each one in yourself. See where it came from and where it goes. Don't skip the ugly ones.

That evening under the ramada they made their rules. The old man, Hollis, who had driven a truck for forty years out of Kingman and was the oldest, let the others talk.

We didn't come here for summer camp, said Marcus, the one who had been a preacher. *Every one of us has seen the inside of a COVID unit, if only on a screen. That door is standing open for every one of us like the door of our own house. You can watch every video she ever made and still not do one thing she said.*

So: phones in a Christmas cookie tin in the office, turned off. Each person in their own space, and never two of them together in one place, not to talk, not to sit, not even to stand. At six in the morning they would walk the river road together, once, without speaking. In the evening they would sit for an hour outside Hollis's trailer, because he was the oldest. Otherwise alone. If anybody got sick, they would go to the post by the office and ring Steve's bell, and everybody would come.

It's not a dinner bell, Hollis said. It was the only thing he said all night.

II. The Bell

Verde Bend · July

In the second week of July Dora went down the bank in the late afternoon with her grandson Nico carrying a cooler. She had made a jug of agua de jamaica, red as a stoplight, and a pan of empanadas de calabaza, and two pounds of grapes from the Safeway because it seemed to her those people did not eat fruit. The park was silent. The trailers had their blinds down. The tents had their flaps tied. Nobody was in the ramada or the bathhouse or the river.

Old Mr. Esquivel was fishing for carp off the gravel bar, as he had every evening for thirty years, and she asked him where they had all gone.

They're here, he said. *Each one in his hole. You want them, ring the bell. They come running.*

So she rang it.

It was louder than she remembered. The sound went down the river and came back off the bluff, and then the doors began to open. They came out of trailers, tents, cab-over campers, the cantaloupe bus, and the mesquite thickets along the bank where some of them had been sitting on folded blankets. She watched them cross the gravel toward her. It was the strangest thing. They came one at a time. Each one by his own path. Two would be coming from the same end of the park, and one would bend wide around the bathhouse so as not to walk beside the other. Sixty people, and no two of them together.

She had raised three children and buried one. She knew what that meant.

All right, she said, when they were standing in front of her. *Who's fighting?*

Nobody, Mrs. Matkovich.

Don't tell me nobody. When you came up to my porch in June you came all together like ducks. Now you come one by one from every direction like you can't stand each other. Somebody's fighting.

Priya, the thin girl with the laptop bag, who had tested software in Chandler until she couldn't anymore, explained it. Each of them sat by

themselves all day, she said, doing the practice. That was the rule. Alone was the point.

What practice?

The thirty-two parts, Priya said. *You go through the body, one thing at a time. Hair, nails, teeth, skin. You find each one in yourself and look at it till you see it's not yours to keep. It goes. All of it goes.*

Dora stood with the jug of jamaica sweating against her hip and thought about it.

Is that only for you people? Or can an old woman do that?

It isn't forbidden to anybody, Hollis said.

Then show me.

Priya got her phone out of the cookie tin, which was breaking the rule; everyone let her. They sat Dora in the office chair on the porch, and she watched all thirty-two videos straight through while the sixty stood in the gravel at a polite distance from one another and the sun went down behind Mingus Mountain. Graciela in her car. The grey concrete of the garage behind her. The red mark of the mask across her nose. *Cabello,* she said in the first one, and then in English: *Hair of the head. Last night I washed a man's hair because his wife couldn't come in. He had a lot of it. Black, a little grey on the sides. I combed it the way she said he liked. He died at fourteen.* And then the word, and the screen went dark.

When she had seen all of them Dora gave the phone back and stood up.

Drink the jamaica before it gets warm, she said, and went up the bank to her house.

III. Thirty-Two

The monsoon · July and August

THE RAINS CAME THAT YEAR LIKE THEY HAD NOT COME IN TWO summers. The Weather Service counts the monsoon from the middle of June to the end of September, but for two years there had been next to nothing, and people in the valley had started to say the word as a joke. In the third week of July a wall of brown dust came up the valley from the

SOUTH IN THE LATE AFTERNOON, A MILE HIGH, AND SWALlowed Cottonwood, and right behind it came the rain. The whole valley smelled of wet creosote and hot stone. The Verde came up brown and fast, full of sticks. Matt's fire company pulled a man and his dog off the roof of a pickup at a low-water crossing. In Flagstaff the water came down off the burned mountain and went through people's houses.

Dora did the practice at her kitchen table at four in the morning, before the heat, with the window open on the noise of the river.

She did not have to look far for any of it. Hair of the head: grey, thin at the crown, the same hair her mother had brushed out every night on the back step in Jerome with a tortoiseshell brush. Nails: ridged, yellow on the big toes. Teeth: eleven of her own and a partial plate she took out at night and put in a glass. Skin: the brown spots on the backs of her hands, which had appeared one summer and stayed. Bones: the left hip, which told her about the weather. The heart, which the cardiologist in Cottonwood listened to every six months with his head tilted like a bird. The blood they drew from her arm every three months for the sugar. She went down the list the way you go down a list at the store, and when she got to the bottom she went back to the top.

She had sat beside Steve for the last nine days in the hospital in Prescott. She had seen what she had seen. So she was not frightened by the list, and it went quickly with her, more quickly than it had gone with any of the sixty. On a morning at the end of July she was standing at the sink with the water running, and she was looking at the backs of her hands under the water, and something that had been holding on in her for seventy-five years let go. It did not hurt. It was like setting down a box of canned goods you had carried in from the car and forgotten you were carrying. She turned off the water. She dried her hands on the towel. She stood in her kitchen and was not afraid of anything.

The old women in Jerome would have had a word for what happened to her after that. She found she could see her sixty. She would be sitting at her table and she would know that the preacher was lying on his back in the bed of his pickup with his fists closed, going over and over something a deacon had said to him in 2019. She would know that Priya had

not slept, and the Mormon mother from Gilbert was crying for her children, and the boy from Flagstaff with the tattoos was angry at his father, who was dead. All of them still caught. Not one of them through.

So she asked herself, the way you would go through a list: did they have what they needed?

A good place? They had the river and the cottonwoods and the bend where the water slowed down. Yes.

Good company? They had each other, and old Hollis in the evenings, and the practice. Yes.

Food?

She looked, and she saw it. Ramen. A jar of peanut butter and a spoon. Gas-station taquitos warmed on a dashboard. Protein bars gone soft in the heat. Beans out of the can, cold. They were losing weight. They were dizzy in the afternoons and they thought the dizziness was spiritual. They were trying to sit still with their stomachs empty and their blood sugar on the floor in a hundred and eight degrees, and she nearly laughed out loud at the kitchen table.

The next day she rang the bell at noon.

They came running, one at a time, each from his own direction, thinking somebody was sick. She stood by the post with her apron on.

Up the bank, she said. *All of you. To the house. Now it's a dinner bell.*

She had set the long folding tables end to end under the big mesquite in her yard, and covered them with oilcloth, and every one of the sixty found at their place exactly the thing they had been wanting at four o'clock that morning and had not told anyone. Hollis found biscuits and sausage gravy. Marcus found cornbread in a skillet and a bowl of greens with a ham hock in them, the way his grandmother in Tallulah had made them, and he sat with his spoon in his hand and could not use it for a while. Priya found dal, yellow, with too much ginger, which was how she liked it and how her mother had never made it. The Mormon mother found a grilled cheese sandwich cut corner to corner. The boy from Flagstaff found a carne asada burro from the truck on Main Street, still in its foil. Dora went among them pouring tea and did not explain anything, and they did not ask, because by then they were all too busy eating.

After that she fed them every day. Nico ran trays down the bank. Matt complained about the grocery bill and paid it. And because they were fed, they slept, and because they slept, their minds came down and got quiet, the way the river came down after a storm and you could see the stones on the bottom again. One by one through August, each of them alone, each in their own place, they finished. That was the word they used among themselves afterward. Not one of them ever said it any bigger than that.

On the last night of September they sat in a circle under the ramada, close together for the first time since June, and each one in turn asked the others to say if he had done anything wrong that summer. Nobody had much to say. Then Hollis spoke for the second time.

That woman held us up, he said. *Without her we'd have quit by August. Let's go tell Graciela.*

In the morning they packed. Dora walked with them down the gravel road as far as the cattle guard, the way her mother had walked people to the edge of the yard in Jerome, and stood there while the cars went over it one by one, rattling.

Come see me, she said to each window. *Don't be strangers. You know where I am.*

IV. The Garage

Phoenix · September

THE SECOND SUMMER OF THE SICKNESS WAS WORSE IN THE hospitals than anyone outside them wanted to know. Over July and August the number of COVID patients in the state's intensive care beds had gone up three times over. The new ones were younger. They came in at twenty-four and thirty-eight and forty-one, and the nurses who had been through the first winter said this one was harder, because the first time nobody had known and this time everybody could have.

Graciela came down the stairwell to the fourth level at ten past seven in the morning. Two of hers had died in the night. She was forty-four and had grown up in the Apostolic church on South Seventh Avenue, where

her grandmother had taught her to read out of a black Reina-Valera with a zipper on it, and she was carrying her lunch bag, which she had not opened.

The sixty were waiting by her car. They were standing close together, talking quietly, which she had not seen them do before.

She looked at them.

You all ate, she said.

They laughed, all of them at once, and then they told her about Dora. The bell. The tables under the mesquite. How she knew what each one of them wanted before they knew it themselves; how they would be sitting in their trailers at four in the morning thinking about their grandmother's greens, and at noon there were the greens.

There were always a few other people in that garage at shift change by then. Strangers who had seen the videos came to stand at the far end of the row and just look at her, and the security man on the golf cart had given up chasing them off. One of them that morning was a man named Shane Goodwin, thirty-four, from Mesa, who sold solar panels door to door when he worked and had been divorced for a year and a half and had watched the thirty-two videos more times than he could count. He listened from behind a concrete pillar to everything the sixty said, and when they had gone he came out and asked Graciela for the practice.

You already have it, she said. *It's thirty-two minutes long.*

I want to do it up there. At that place. With her.

Graciela unlocked her car. She looked tired enough to lie down on the concrete.

Then go, she said.

V. What He Wanted

Verde Bend · October

Shane drove up the Black Canyon Freeway on a Friday afternoon and came over the cattle guard after dark. Dora's son had left a key under a rock on the step of the trailer where Hollis had stayed. He opened the door and turned on the light and stood there. Nobody had

been in it for two weeks. There was dust on everything, a dead moth in the sink, a smell of hot plastic. He had driven a hundred miles. He thought: *I can't clean this tonight. I wish she'd send somebody.*

Ten minutes later there was a knock. A tall boy of fifteen stood on the step with a broom, a bucket, and a bottle of Pine-Sol.

My grandma said, said Nico, and swept the trailer out, and wiped the sink, and went away.

Shane sat on the clean bed. He was thirsty. He wanted something cold and sweet, not water. When he opened the door to get air there was a jar on the step, sweating in the dark, red as a stoplight, with ice in it.

In the morning he woke up thinking about rice pudding, the warm kind, with butter melting on top, which his grandmother had made in Safford when he was small. There was a covered bowl on the step. Arroz con leche, still warm, with a pat of butter going soft in the middle and cinnamon on the butter. When he had eaten it he thought, almost as a joke, *a machaca burro, with green chile,* and before he had rinsed the bowl it was on the step in its foil.

He sat on the step and looked at the foil for a long time.

Then he thought, *I want to see her. I want her to come herself. With something hot.*

She came down the bank at noon in her housedress with a pot of caldo de queso wrapped in a towel, potatoes and green chile and white cheese going soft in the broth, and a plate of her mother-in-law's povitica, the walnut bread rolled up like a carpet, cut in slices. She set it all on the picnic table and sat down across from him while he ate.

When he was finished he said, *You're Matt's mother.*

That's right, mijo.

Mrs. Matkovich, do you know what people are thinking?

Why do you ask me that?

Because everything I've thought since I got here, you've sent. The broom. The jamaica. The rice. The burro. You.

Lots of people know what other people are thinking.

I'm not asking lots of people. I'm asking you.

Dora gathered the spoon and the bowl and the plate and stacked them.

People who can't read anybody's mind do the same thing, mijo, she said. *Mothers do it all day long.*

She went back up the bank, and Shane sat at the picnic table and was afraid.

He knew what was in his head. He knew it better than anyone. He had been sitting with it for a year and a half in an apartment in Mesa with the blinds down. Kayla, and the man from her gym she had left him for, and the things he would like to do to that man in a parking lot. The girl at the Circle K counter that morning, and what he had thought about her. How much money the guy in the next trailer down probably had. His brother's new truck. Who he could beat in a fight. Who he could get to buy panels if he lied a little. Contempt for the sixty, for their pickle-jar tea and their clean faces. Contempt for himself. All of it going through his head like traffic, day and night, the good thoughts and the rotten ones, and the rotten ones were most of it. And she could see it. She sat at her table up there on the bank and watched it go by.

One wrong thought, he told himself, and she'll throw me off this place like somebody caught stealing out of the office.

In the morning he packed the car. She was at the office when he dropped the key.

Where are you going, mijo?

Back to Graciela.

Stay a while. You just got here.

I can't stay, Mrs. Matkovich. I have to go.

He went over the cattle guard fast, rattling, and did not look in the mirror.

VI. Above Everything

Phoenix · October

He waited for her by the car on the fourth level. She came out of the stairwell at ten past seven and saw him and stopped.

You're not up there.

I can't be up there.

Why not?

She knows everything I think. Everything. And I think garbage, Graciela. All day. You don't know what goes on in here. He put his hand flat on his chest as if it were a door. *One bad thought and she'll run me off that place like a thief.*

Graciela set her lunch bag on the roof of the Corolla.

That's the place for you, she said. *That's exactly the place.*

I can't. I won't.

Okay. She leaned on the car. *Can you guard one thing?*

What thing?

Just what goes on in there. Your thinking. Not her. Not what she sees or doesn't see. Not anything else. Just that one thing. It's hard enough by itself. It goes wherever it wants. It lands on anything. She shut her eyes for a moment, standing up. *My grandma's Bible has it. She made me say it every night before I could have the light off.*

> *Sobre toda cosa guardada guarda tu corazón; porque de él mana la vida.*
>
> *— Proverbios 4:23*

She said it again for him in English, her own way, slowly. *Of everything you're guarding, guard your heart. Your whole life comes out of it.*

That's it?

That's it. Go back up there. Don't worry about anything else.

The man in the parking booth on the ground level had been leaning out his window to listen, as he did most mornings now. When Shane had driven out past him, he took a yellow Post-it off the pad by his register and wrote on it, in capitals, GUARD ONE THING, and stuck it to the inside of the booth's glass, where it stayed through the winter and the next summer, curling in the heat, until somebody painted the booth.

VII. The Hundredth

Verde Bend · November

Dora was at her kitchen table on the Sunday afternoon when the car came back over the cattle guard. She did not get up to look.

He found a teacher, she said, to nobody, and got up and put the beans on.

He took Hollis's trailer again. He did not think about her anymore, or about what she could see. He thought about his thinking, and when it went somewhere, he went and got it and brought it back, the way you bring back a dog that has got out of the yard, without hitting it. Hair of the head. Nails. Teeth. Skin. The food came every day on the step, the right food, and he ate it and washed the bowl and set it back out. In the mornings he walked the river road alone. On the third morning there was a rattlesnake stretched across the path in the first sun, as thick as his wrist. He stood a long time. Then he found a long cottonwood stick and lifted the snake gently into the brush, and it went.

In a few days he finished.

He was sitting in a camp chair facing the river when it happened, and afterward he sat on there in the clear blank peace of it for a long time. The first thing he thought when he could think again was of her. *She held me up. Without that woman I'd never have got here.* And then, because the sixty had talked about such things on the long nights and he had half believed them, he thought: *Was it only this time? Or has she been holding me up before?*

He looked back.

He saw a hundred lives less one, and in every one of them she was his wife. In a rooming house in a mining town on a mountain she put something in his coffee. In a farmhouse with a dirt floor she opened the door at night to a man with a knife, and stood back. On a riverboat, in a city of canals, in a village of reed houses, in a stone house in the snow, again and again, ninety-nine times, she loved somebody else and he was in the way, and she put him out of the way. He saw all of it at once, the way you see a

whole valley from a bluff. He sat in the camp chair in the sun with his hands on his knees.

My God, he thought. *What that woman has done.*

• • •

Up the bank Dora sat at her kitchen table with a cup of coffee going cold and saw that he had finished. She saw him think of her and say she had held him up. She saw him look back. She saw what he saw, all of it, the coffee and the knife and the door, and what he thought of her.

She did not argue with any of it. It was true. She turned her cup a little on the oilcloth and looked further back herself, past the ninety-nine, and found the one she was looking for.

Then she said out loud, in her kitchen, in an ordinary voice, as if he were sitting across the table:

Look further, mijo.

He heard it down by the river as plainly as if she had been standing beside his chair.

So he looked further. Past the stone house and the reed houses and all the rest, back to the oldest of them, older than any name for a place. A river much like this one, low and green, with stones in it. He was asleep on the bank in the heat of the day. She was his wife there too, and there was another man there too, waiting in the trees, and she was standing over him with a stone in both hands, a river stone the size of a loaf of bread. He saw how long she stood. He saw her arms shake with the weight of it.

Then she set it down on the sand beside his head, carefully, so as not to wake him. She went down to the water and washed her hands. Then she came back and sat beside him until he woke.

Shane sat in the camp chair and was so glad that he could not move. *She held me up,* he thought. *She has always been holding me up.* He sat there in the gladness of it, and went over the thirty-two one last time, slowly, from the hair of the head to the urine, and found nothing in any of it that was his, and was glad of that too.

• • •

Matt found him in the morning when he came down to check the water line. He was sitting in the camp chair facing the river with Dora's blue quilt over his knees and his hands open on top of it. The deputy came, and then the medical examiner's van from Prescott. They said his heart had stopped. They could not find any reason for it to stop. He was thirty-four and had nothing wrong with him.

Dora went down the bank after the van had gone over the cattle guard. The wind was coming up the river from the south, the last warm wind of the year, turning the cottonwood leaves over so they showed their pale sides. Out over Mingus Mountain a single grey cloud was letting its rain down in long veils that hung in the air and dried away before they reached the ground.

The wind took hold of Steve's bell on its post and swung it a little, and the clapper rocked toward the lip. Before it could ring, she put her hand on the bronze and held it still until the wind had passed.

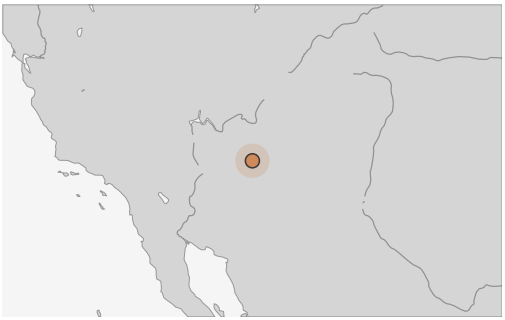
Background

The verse

> *It is good to tame the mind, which is difficult to hold in and flighty, rushing wherever it listeth; a tamed mind brings happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 35, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, sixty monks spend the rains retreat in the village of Mātika, where the headman's mother builds them a monastery. They agree that no two of them will ever be together and that a bell will be struck only if someone falls sick. When she strikes it herself and sees them come one by one, she thinks they have quarrelled; they teach her the meditation on the thirty-two parts of the body, and she attains insight before they do. Seeing that only their food is lacking, she feeds them exactly what each one wishes, and they reach the goal. Another monk hears of her and comes, wishes for one thing after another, and receives each; frightened that she knows his every thought, he flees back to the Buddha, who tells him this is the very place for him and that he need guard only one thing, his mind. He returns, attains, and looking back sees ninety-nine lives in which she, as his wife, killed him; she tells

him to look further, and in the hundredth he sees that she spared him. Read the full commentary story, or about the meditation on the thirty-two parts of the body.



Cottonwood, Arizona

The Verde Valley, 2021

Dora's family history follows the valley's. Jerome, built on Cleopatra Hill above the Verde, was one of the great copper camps of the West; by 1930 about sixty percent of its people were Latino, alongside Irish, Italian and Slavic miners. The United Verde mine ran from 1876 to 1953, and when it closed the town shrank to fewer than a hundred people. Its smelter town, Clarkdale, founded by William A. Clark in 1912 on the river below, closed its smelter the same year and left a long black slag pile along the Verde.

In June 2021 a record heat wave struck the Southwest, and Phoenix hit 118°F on June 17. After two nearly rainless summers, the North American monsoon returned in force: Tucson had its wettest July on record, and floods off the 2019 Museum Fire burn scar ran through Flagstaff neighborhoods. At the same time the Delta variant filled Arizona's hospitals. COVID patients in the state's intensive care beds tripled over July and August, the patients were younger than in earlier waves and mostly unvaccinated, and nurses who had worked through the first winter described themselves as burned out. More on the COVID-19 pandemic in Arizona.

After the story of a certain monk and the mother of Mātika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 35). The original. Scripture from the Reina-Valera 1909. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3·3

Clear Hands

… and let thy principles be brief and fundamental.
— Marcus Aurelius, Meditations IV.3

The way it got told to me, on the back tables at the Thursday weekly on Spring Mountain Road.

I. The List

Summerlin, Las Vegas · 2011 *and* 2012

Goodwin Sayre was eighteen and his father built houses. Sayre Homes had put up a good part of the northwest valley, and after the crash, when whole streets of it stood empty with the pools gone green, his father had bought the paper back cheap and waited. By 2011 there was money again. There was a house out toward Red Rock with a room over the garage, and in the room were two consoles, two of the flat monitors the tournaments used, and a hole in the drywall beside the door with a calendar hung over it.

He played Street Fighter. He had played it online since he was fourteen and was good the way a boy alone in a room gets good, and every loss went through him like something swallowed wrong. He could feel it coming in the second round. Heat behind the eyes, cold hands, then a noise in his head like a room full of people talking about him. Afterward he couldn't eat. He had thought that winning more would stop it. He won more, and it got worse.

Ro Mendez came to the house on Tuesdays. Ro was thirty-one and ran the Thursday weekly in the back of a card shop on Spring Mountain Road. He gave lessons for forty dollars an hour and whatever was in the refrigerator, which at the Sayres' was a great deal. One Tuesday in the

fall, after Ro had taken ten straight games without seeming to try, Goodwin set his stick down on the carpet.

I want to stop feeling like this. Tell me how.

Ro looked at the calendar on the wall. It still said June.

Okay. Give.

Give what?

You've got money. Half the kids at my weekly can't cover the five dollars at the door. Cover it. Buy the pizza every other Thursday. We never have enough setups, so bring yours. Evo's in July, right in the monsoon, and there'll be guys in from Fresno and El Paso who plan on sleeping in a Corolla. Put them up. Whatever comes to you, cut it three ways. A third for school, a third to live on, a third for the scene.

Goodwin did all of it, in that order. In March he came back.

Is there anything else I should be doing?

Yeah. Ro counted on his fingers. *Don't quit out of a match. Don't blame the stick. Don't play for money you don't have on you. Shake the hand. Show up when you said you would.*

He kept the five and came back and asked again. Ro gave him five more, about sleep, about eating before a bracket, about watching his own losses with the sound off, and he kept those too. By then they had a name for him on Spring Mountain Road. Nobody had ever seen him skip a step or take two at once, so they called him Checklist, and he answered to it.

In August, when the six players who had slept at his father's house over Evo weekend had gone home, he asked one more time.

Yeah, Ro said. *Quit school. Come live in the house.*

He moved in on Labor Day.

II. The House

Off Jones Boulevard · fall 2012

The house was a four-bedroom rental that a headset company paid for. Five players lived in it with an analyst and a manager, and the living room had been cleared down to a row of stations and a camera on a tripod.

The analyst was called Ko. He had the whole game in a three-ring binder and again in a spreadsheet with eleven tabs: thirty-nine characters, and for every move of every one of them the number of sixtieths of a second it took to come out, the number it stayed out, the number it left you standing there afterward with your arm extended. Ryu's uppercut came out in three. Some combinations had to be struck inside a single sixtieth or they did not happen. Whenever Goodwin sat down beside him Ko had the binder open. *Here this is correct. Here that is incorrect. You pressed a button there. You can't ever press a button there.*

The manager was Dana Whitlock, who had run a call center before this and ran the house off a laminated sheet on the refrigerator. Up by nine. Eight hours on the stream. Nothing to drink the night before a bracket and nothing posted for an hour after one. Wrist stretches on a timer. The sheet had a paragraph on where the heel of the hand should rest on the stick, with a photograph. *That's fine. That isn't. That's how we do it here. That's how we don't.*

They were both right. He could see it, and it made things worse.

By November he had a thought he could say word for word. *I got into this to stop feeling a certain way. There isn't room in here to stretch out my hands. People live regular lives and come out all right. I'll go back to school. My father has an office with a door waiting for my name.*

After that he stopped opening the practice mode and stopped watching his losses. He dropped eleven pounds he didn't have to drop. Under the light strips in the living room his skin went the yellow of a legal pad. The veins came up along his forearms, and the skin over his knuckles cracked and scabbed and cracked again and left flecks on the buttons.

The two youngest in the house were seventeen. They found him one night sitting at a station with the monitor off.

Check. Wherever you sit down lately you look sick. What did you do?

I didn't do anything. I'm not happy here.

Why not?

He told them. They told Ko and Dana, who talked in the kitchen for a while with the door shut. Then Dana came out with her keys.

We're going to see Uncle. Bring a jacket. He keeps the garage cold.

III. The Garage

North Las Vegas · 2:40 a.m.

Dennis Kaneshiro was forty-four. He had grown up in Kalihi and come to Las Vegas at twenty, like half of Kalihi, and he dealt blackjack and pai gow on swing shift at a downtown house where the coffee shop served oxtail soup after midnight and the players at his table talked to him in pidgin. People who had been around in the early nineties said that for three years there had been no Street Fighter cabinet between San Diego and Seattle he could be beaten on. Then he married and had two daughters, and the tournaments saw him about once a year.

He got off at two and was home by half past. From then until half past three he played, with his wife and the girls asleep on the other side of the wall, and then he slept until it was time to drive them to school. One hour. Players who trained ten hours a day drove out to North Las Vegas at that hour to sit beside him, and they drove home quiet.

He was at the utility sink in his black-and-whites with the bow tie off, washing his hands, when Dana's car pulled in.

What brings you folks?

This one isn't happy in the house, Ko said.

Dennis dried his hands on a shop towel. He looked at Goodwin's knuckles before he looked at his face.

That true?

Yes.

How come?

I got into this because I wanted to stop feeling a certain way. Ko taught me the frames. Dana taught me the rules. They're right about all of it. There isn't room left to stretch out my hands. I think a person can get free of it living a regular life, so I'm going home.

Dennis hung up the towel.

If you could watch one thing, you wouldn't have to watch the rest.

What thing?

Can you watch what you're thinking?

Goodwin considered it honestly, the way he considered everything.

I can do that.

Then watch that. Only that.

He pulled a folding chair around and sat. *Where I work there's a procedure for everything these two hands do. How I hold the deck. Which hand goes to the rack. There's a camera over my table, and somebody upstairs whose whole job is my hands. When I walk away from a game I do this.* He clapped once, softly, and turned his hands over, palms and then backs. *Clear hands. So upstairs can see I'm carrying nothing off. My first year I tried to hold every procedure in my head at the same time. I broke out to the elbows and shorted somebody about once a night. Nobody can watch all that. So I watch up here. If I know what I've got in my head, my hands keep procedure by themselves. If I don't know, the binder can't save me. No disrespect to the binder.*

Ko, standing by the water heater, lifted one shoulder.

There was a lunch cooler on the workbench. Dennis took a paperback out of it with a cover gone soft as cloth, the kind that had cost a dollar new. *A dealer gets twenty minutes off out of every eighty. Sixteen years of twenty minutes. This guy ran Rome and wrote it down for himself at night, in a tent.* He found the place without hunting for it.

> *We ought then to check in the series of our thoughts everything that is without a purpose and useless, but most of all the over-curious feeling and the malignant; and a man should use himself to think of those things only about which if one should suddenly ask, What hast thou now in thy thoughts? with perfect openness thou mightest immediately answer, This or That.*
>
> *— Marcus Aurelius, Meditations III.4*

That's all he's got, Dennis said. *Somebody asks you cold what you're thinking, and you can tell them. This or that.* He turned forward to a page with the corner folded.

> *Therefore the mind which is free from passions is a citadel, for man has nothing more secure to which he can fly for refuge and for the future be inexpugnable.*
>
> *— Marcus Aurelius, Meditations VIII.48*

He put the book back in the cooler. *Sit down. Ryu, both sides.*

They played. In the middle of the second round Dennis spoke without taking his eyes off the screen.

What have you got in your head?

Goodwin had a lie ready and let it go. *That I'm about to drop this.*

Okay. That's one. Now you know where it is.

He dropped it anyway. In the next game Dennis asked again. *That my dad's going to want to know what I do all day. This or that,* said Dennis, and took the round. It went on that way until the clock on the microwave said a quarter past three, and somewhere before then Dennis quit asking and Goodwin went on asking himself. The room full of people talking was still there. But when he turned and looked at it, it was one thought at a time, and each one, looked at, sat down.

He lost every game. On the drive back he noticed he was hungry.

At half past three Dennis switched off the monitor and stood. He clapped once, softly, and turned his hands over above the stick, and did not seem to know he had done it.

IV. Pools

Bally's Event Center · July 12, 2013

He stayed in the house. The binder was still the binder and the sheet was still on the refrigerator. He kept what he could of both and watched the one thing, and over the spring he found that most of the rest got kept without his standing over it. He ate. The skin closed over his knuckles and came in pink. Ko, who had heard all of it from beside the water heater, took to stopping a session in the middle to ask a player what he had in his head. The seventeen-year-olds started saying it to each other across the kitchen, *this or that*, as a joke at first.

Evo that year drew more than thirty-five hundred players to the Strip. Six of them slept at his father's house.

His pool was called on Friday morning, at a long table under ballroom lights with a number taped to the monitor. He won twice. His third match was against a boy from Fresno who had his sleeping bag in the

Sayres' guest room. In the last round it came the way it always had, the heat and the cold hands and the room full of people. He turned and looked. *They're all going to see.* There it was. He let it sit where it was, and his hands did what they knew, and he lost the round by a sliver. He lost the next match to someone else and was out of the tournament by noon.

He shook the hand. He unplugged his stick and wound the cord. Then, standing over the station, he clapped once, softly, and turned his hands over above the buttons, palms and then backs.

What's that? said the boy from Fresno.

Nothing. Clearing.

He was hungry. He had six guests and a list in his pocket of what each of them would eat, and he went to see about lunch.

Background

The verse

> *Let the wise man guard his thoughts, for they are difficult to perceive, very artful, and they rush wherever they list: thoughts well guarded bring happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 36, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich man's son asks a monk who comes to his house for alms how to be released from suffering. The monk tells him to give: meal tickets, fortnightly food, lodging for the rains, bowls and robes, a third of everything he has. He does it all and asks if there is anything else. He is given the five precepts, then the ten, then told to go forth, and because he does each thing in order he comes to be called Anupubba, "Gradual." As a monk he has one teacher who drills him in the Abhidhamma and another who drills him in the monastic rule, until he decides there is "not even room for me to stretch out my hands" and that he may as well be free as a householder. He stops practicing and grows thin, jaundiced and scabbed. His teachers bring him to the Buddha, who tells him that if he can guard one thing he need not guard the rest: his own thoughts. Read the full commentary story.

Las Vegas, Nevada

Las Vegas and the fighting-game scene, 2013

The fighting-game community grew out of arcades in the early 1990s and still runs largely on small local weeklies and volunteer organizers. Its largest gathering, the Evolution Championship Series, moved to Las Vegas in 2005. Evo 2013 took place on July 12–14 in the Bally's Event Center and the ballroom of Paris Las Vegas, with open registration and a record 3,538 competitors across nine games, among them Super Street Fighter IV: Arcade Edition. The game runs at sixty frames a second, and serious players study "frame data," tables of how many frames each attack takes to start, stay active and recover. Some of its combinations allowed a window of a single frame. Players speak of protecting their "mental" much as the verse speaks of guarding thoughts.

Las Vegas has so many residents from Hawai'i that islanders call it the ninth island, and for decades the downtown casinos have courted them. Table-game dealers work under surveillance cameras and a long list of hand procedures. Before leaving a table a dealer "clears" the hands, turning them palm up and palm down for the camera to show they are empty; the usual rotation is a twenty-minute break after an hour or so of dealing (see croupier). The *Meditations* of Marcus Aurelius were written in Greek as private notes, some of them on campaign. The passages here are from George Long's translation of 1862, the text of many cheap paperback editions.

After the story of a dissatisfied bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 36). The original. Passages from the *Meditations* of Marcus Aurelius, tr. George Long (1862). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

3·4

Three Shirts

Thou understandest my thought afar off.
— Psalm 139:2 (ASV)

***So this is how I heard it, then, out at the Starview on old* 41.**

I. The Starview

Outagamie County, Wisconsin · 1948

Walt Kuehl came home from the Pacific in the fall of 1945 with the red arrow of the Thirty-second Division on his shoulder and a habit of sitting with his back to a wall. For three years he worked the wet end of a paper machine at the mill in Kaukauna and drank most of what they paid him. He was not mean about it. He was quiet, and then he was gone for a day or two, and then he was back at the machine.

In the summer of 1948 Harold and Irene Voss opened a drive-in on forty acres of Harold's father's hayfield east of the highway. It had a screen tower of fir planks painted white, two hundred and forty speaker posts in curved rows, and a cinder-block building in the middle of the field that was a snack bar downstairs and a projection booth up. They called it the Starview. Harold ran the projectors. Irene sat in the box office at the gate and took the money.

One night in August, after the second feature, when the last cars had pulled out onto the highway and Harold had shut down the arcs, Irene walked the rows with a flashlight to pick up the speakers people had dropped in the gravel. In the back row she found one car still parked with its speaker hanging in the window and a man sitting in it.

What she said to him nobody ever learned. Walt said later that it was about nine words, and that was all he would say about it.

The next evening he came back sober and asked Harold if he could use somebody in the booth. Within the week the men at the mill said he had gone strange, and his mother said he had gone quiet, and inside a month he was the man he would be for the rest of his life. He moved into the room behind the booth, with a cot and a chair and a hot plate. He gave his Plymouth to his brother-in-law and walked wherever he needed to go. He owned three shirts, one on him and one on the line and one in the drawer, and when one wore through he bought another one like it. Nobody saw him take a drink again, or raise his voice, or want anything, and though people watched him for years, nobody could say he had lost anything by it either. Dogs came up the long drive from the highway to lie in the shade under the booth stairs.

His youngest sister, Marlene, had married Don Pagel from Combined Locks that spring. When her boy came the next June she named him Walter, after her brother, because she said he was the steadiest thing she knew. So there were two Walts at the Starview, and people called the boy Marlene's Walt, or Little Walt, long after he stood taller than his uncle.

Harold Voss died in the winter of 1961, shoveling snow off the snack bar roof. Irene kept the place. She sat in the box office the way she always had, under a lamp, with a cash drawer and a roll of tickets, and she did not say much. When she told a lot boy *That'll do,* it did.

Little Walt started in the booth at fifteen. His uncle taught him the two machines and the carbons, which burned down like pencils in the arc lamp and had to be fed and trimmed, and the threading path, and the loop, and the dots. A reel ran twenty minutes. Near the end of every reel a small pale circle flashed in the upper right corner of the screen, there and gone, too quick to see unless you were waiting for it. That was the motor cue, and you started the second machine. Seven seconds later came the second dot, and you threw the changeover, and the picture went on from one machine to the other without a seam, and two hundred cars never knew anything had happened.

You have to be there for it, his uncle said. That was about all he said. In twenty years the Starview's screen had never once gone white.

II. Two Shirts

Sister Bay, Door County · Labor Day 1968

That May the man who ran the booth at the Peninsula Outdoor, north of Sister Bay, got his notice from the draft board, and Irene's cousin Ruth Bergstrom called long distance to ask if she could borrow the boy. So Little Walt spent the summer he turned nineteen on the Door, sleeping in a cabin behind a cherry orchard and running the show for people up from Chicago and Milwaukee, who honked at everything. He picked cherries in July for the money. He swam off the town dock on his nights off. He did not miss a changeover all summer, and he thought about that more than he meant to, and wished his uncle could know it without his having to say it.

On Labor Day night, after the last show of the season, Mrs. Bergstrom met him at the foot of the booth stairs with a paper sack from the store in Sturgeon Bay. In it were two wool shirts, red and black check, the heavy kind, one a medium and one a large.

One for you and one for your uncle, she said. *You tell him thank you for the loan of you.*

He drove home the next morning down 57 in his brother's old Chevrolet with the sack on the seat beside him. Somewhere before Green Bay he decided that the large one was for his uncle. It was the better shirt. It was cut fuller, with longer tails, and the buttons were sewn on tighter. His uncle had worn the same three gray shirts for as long as Little Walt could remember, gone white at the elbows and soft as flannel, and it seemed to him that a man who had stood in a hot booth for twenty years ought to have one good thing that somebody gave him. That was what he told himself. He did not tell himself the other part, which was that he wanted to see his uncle put it on.

III. The Booth

The Starview · the Saturday after Labor Day

After Labor Day the Starview ran Fridays and Saturdays only, until the frost. Little Walt got out there a little after three. Irene's Buick was gone from beside the box office, which meant she had driven his uncle into Appleton to the Greyhound depot to pick up the film.

He climbed the outside stairs to the booth. It was close and hot under the tar roof and smelled the way it always smelled, of carbon ash and machine oil and old popcorn coming up through the floor. He swept the ash and the film trimmings into the dustpan. He emptied the coffee can of carbon stubs. He washed the two port glasses with newspaper and vinegar until the white screen at the far end of the field stood in each of them clean as a sheet of paper. He set his uncle's chair by the rewind bench. He went down to the snack bar and filled a dishpan with water from the cold tap and carried it up without spilling and stirred in a handful of Epsom salts from the box on his uncle's shelf, because his uncle stood all night and his feet were bad. He put the paper sack with the shirt in it on the shelf above the rewind bench, where he could reach it. Then he stood at the port and watched the drive.

A few blackbirds walked the rows between the speaker posts. The screen stood white at the end of the field with nothing on it. Toward five the Buick pulled off the highway and stopped at the foot of the drive, and his uncle got out with the film case on his shoulder and the lunch pail in his other hand, and the Buick went on toward town, and his uncle started walking up the quarter mile of gravel in the sun.

Little Walt went down the stairs two at a time and met him halfway. He took the film case, which weighed forty pounds, and the lunch pail, and walked beside him. His uncle looked at him and smiled.

Look at you, he said. *Brown as a nut.*

In the booth Little Walt sat him in the chair and knelt and unlaced his shoes. His uncle let him. He pulled off the socks, which were darned at the heels, and his uncle put his feet in the pan and let out his breath. Little Walt brought him water in the jelly glass from the jug on the sill.

Then he folded that day's *Post-Crescent* in thirds and stood beside the chair and fanned him.

How was the Peninsula?

Good. I didn't miss one all summer.

No, his uncle said, as if he had known that already. *You wouldn't have.*

He meant to give him the shirt right then. He did not. He wanted it to come at the right time, though he could not have said what the right time was, and so the sack stayed on the shelf while they ate their sandwiches on the stairs and the sun went down behind the screen tower and the first cars began to come up the drive with their headlights on and stop at Irene's window.

IV. Mink

The same night · the first feature

By nine the lot was full. The picture was *Yours, Mine and Ours,* which had been playing all summer, a widow with eight children marrying a widower with ten, and the laughter came up out of the field in waves through two hundred little speakers, a fraction behind the picture. The arc lamps hissed in their housings. The heat of them filled the booth until the air above the machines shook. Moths came to the ports and beat at the glass, and some of them got in through the vent and went into the beam, and showed on the screen as soft gray birds the size of cows that crossed Lucille Ball's kitchen and were gone.

His uncle sat between changeovers with his feet back in his shoes and his hands on his knees, the way he sat, and Little Walt stood beside him and fanned him with the *Post-Crescent*. After the third reel he reached down the sack and took out the large shirt and laid it across his uncle's knees.

Mrs. Bergstrom sent this. It's for you. I picked you the big one.

His uncle unfolded it and held it up into the light from the port, and rubbed the wool between his thumb and finger.

That's a good shirt, he said. *I've got my three. You wear it.*

I got it for you. I was thinking of you the whole way down.

I know you were. I've got three shirts, Walt. You wear it.

Please. It would mean something to me if you wore it.

It's a real good shirt, his uncle said, and folded it along its creases and laid it on the bench beside him, and that was all.

Little Walt went on fanning. Out in the field the eighteen children were all talking at once, and a horn honked at it, and somebody laughed. He had been his uncle's nephew for nineteen years and his helper in this booth for four. He had carried his film and swept his ash and filled his dishpan, and the man would not take a shirt off him. Well, then. If that was how it was, he did not see what he was doing up here. He could quit. Plenty of people quit. He could go on at the mill.

He did not want to go on at the mill. A person had to live on something, though.

He would sell the big shirt. Duane at the snack bar had been wanting a shirt like that; Duane would give him eight dollars for it. He would put the eight with the forty-one in the coffee can in his closet and buy a pair of breeder mink off the man out past Hortonville, a male and a female. Mink are bred in March. They have five kits, six. He would keep the females and pelt the males, and in three years he would have forty, and in five a shed, and then two, the long low sheds you see out by Medford with the wire pens up on legs and the feed truck coming every morning. Then he would ask Carol Gloudemans from the snack bar, who had a space between her front teeth and laughed at everything, and she would say yes. They would have a boy, and they would name him Walter.

And one summer night he would put Carol and the boy in the Ford and drive out here to show the boy to his uncle. He would park in the back row. And walking up between the posts in the dark, with the picture going, he would say, *Give him here, I'll carry him.* And she would say, *You take the thermos. I've got him.* And he would say, *Give him here,* and she would say, *I've got him,* and go ahead of him with the boy up on her shoulder. And her heel would catch in a speaker cord. And she would go down on the gravel, and the boy would roll out of her arms in front of a car that was coming slow down the row on its parking lights.

He saw the boy. He saw the tire. He saw Carol on her knees with her hands out. He heard himself say it to her: *You wouldn't let me carry my own son. You couldn't carry him and you wouldn't let me.* And he brought his hand down on her as hard as he could.

And Little Walt, standing in the booth with the newspaper folded in his fist, brought it down hard on the top of his uncle's head.

The sound was small. His uncle did not move for a moment. Then he put his hand up to his hair, and took it down, and looked at it, and looked at his nephew.

You never did get her, Walt, he said, quietly. *What did an old man do to you?*

Little Walt stood there. The whole of it came up in him at once, the mink and the sheds and the space between Carol's teeth and the parking lights and the tire, and he understood that his uncle had seen it, every bit, as plainly as if it had gone out through the port and onto the screen over two hundred cars. He dropped the newspaper. He went out the booth door and down the stairs, and he ran.

V. The Box Office

The Starview · the same night

He ran across the lot between the rows with the picture enormous above him. Faces turned in windshields. A woman in a Rambler said *Hey!* He tripped on a cord and kept his feet and went on toward the back fence and the cornfield, where it was dark.

The Hoffmann brothers, who worked the lot with flashlights, saw him go, and so did Duane, coming out of the snack bar with a tray of coffee, and the two Gloudemans girls behind the counter. Duane put the tray down on a car hood. They caught him at the fence. He was not hard to catch; he had stopped there with his hands on the top wire, not knowing what came next. They walked him back between the cars, one at each elbow, Carol Gloudemans behind with Duane's flashlight, and nobody said anything, and they brought him to the box office.

Irene Voss sat under the lamp with the cash drawer open, counting the night's dollar bills into piles of twenty. She looked up at the four of them in her window.

What's this.

He ran out of the booth, Mrs. Voss, said the older Hoffmann. *In the middle of the reel. He was going over the fence.*

Walt. Is that so?

Yes, ma'am.

She opened the door of the box office, which nobody but Harold had ever come in by, and said, *Come in here. You boys go on back to work.* He went in. There was a stool and a cooler, and she pointed at the cooler and he sat on it.

Now. Why would you do a thing like that?

I don't want to do it anymore.

Do what.

Any of it. I hit him. I hit my uncle.

She waited. So he told her. He told her about the Peninsula and the two shirts, and the big one and the little one, and the three times his uncle would not take it, and Duane and the eight dollars, and the coffee can, and the mink and the sheds and Carol, and the boy, and the speaker cord, and the parking lights, and his hand, and the *Post-Crescent.* He told it to the end. When he got to the end he could not look at her, so he looked out her little window at the field.

Irene squared a pile of bills and set it in the drawer.

Well, she said. *Don't be so upset. You're not the first.* She nodded at the window. *Look out there. Two hundred cars. You think they're all watching that picture? Half of them are in Green Bay. Some of them are in Saigon. Some of them are in Florida with money they don't have. A mind goes off a long ways by itself, Walt. It goes alone. It doesn't take the body along, it doesn't need it. It gets in there behind your eyes where nobody can see it and it does what it wants. You don't stop it going. You go and fetch it back. Every time, you go and fetch it back.*

She was quiet a minute. Up on the screen the big family went on talking all at once, without a sound.

My mother used to say this, she said, and she said it plainly, the way she would read off the price of a carload.

> *Whither shall I go from thy Spirit? Or whither shall I flee from thy presence? … If I say, Surely the darkness shall overwhelm me, And the light about me shall be night; Even the darkness hideth not from thee, But the night shineth as the day: The darkness and the light are both alike to thee.*
>
> *— Psalm 139:7, 11–12 (ASV)*

You ran off in the dark, she said, *and here you are in my box office with the light on.* She took a twenty out of the drawer and put it back. *Go on up. He's on the second machine by himself, and it's coming up on the end of the reel.*

VI. Changeover

The booth · the second feature

His uncle was standing at the port of the first machine when he came in. He did not turn around. He tipped his head toward the second machine, which was threaded and waiting with its douser down, and Little Walt went and stood at it with his hand on the switch and his eye to the port.

The newspaper was on the floor where he had dropped it. The shirt lay folded on the rewind bench.

He watched the upper right corner of the screen. He thought about the mink, and the thought went out a long way, to the sheds out by Medford, and he went after it and brought it back. He thought about the space between Carol Gloudemans's teeth, and fetched that back too. He thought about the tire, and his hand, and it was a long way to go for that one, and he went and got it. Out in the field two hundred people sat in the dark in their cars and went wherever they went. A moth crossed the beam. The corner of the screen was gray and still.

Then the first dot came, a small pale circle, there and gone, and he was there for it. He started the motor and counted. At seven the second dot came, and he threw the changeover, and the picture went on from the one machine to the other, and nobody out in the field knew that anything at all had happened.

His uncle shut down the first arc and lifted the empty reel off. Then he took the folded shirt off the bench and held it out.

You wear it, he said.

It was the big one. Little Walt put it on over his T-shirt, and the sleeves came down past his knuckles, and he turned the cuffs back twice and stood at the port, and the beam went out over his shoulder across the field to the screen, full of dust and moths, all of it lit and none of it caught.

Background

The verse

> *Those who bridle their mind which travels far, moves about alone, is without a body, and hides in the chamber (of the heart), will be free from the bonds of Mara (the tempter).*
>
> Dhammapada 37, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, an elder named Saṅgharakkhita is ordained after hearing the Buddha and becomes an arahant within days. His youngest sister names her son after him, and the boy is ordained under his uncle. After a rains retreat the nephew is given two robes, one seven cubits long and one eight, and sets his heart on giving the longer one to his uncle. He sweeps the elder's quarters, sets out water for his feet, and fans him, but the elder refuses the robe because he already has a full set. Still fanning, the nephew drifts into a daydream: he will leave the order, sell the robe, buy a she-goat, grow rich on her kids, marry, and take his wife and son in a cart to visit his uncle, and on the road his wife will drop the child under the wheels and he will strike her with his stick. His fan comes down on the elder's head. The elder, who has seen the whole daydream, says, "You did not succeed in hitting the woman; what has an old elder done to deserve a beating?" The nephew flees, is caught by the young monks, and is brought to the Buddha, who tells him not to be troubled, because the mind travels far. Read the full commentary story. The daydream belongs to a family of tales that includes the milkmaid and her pail; see The Milkmaid and Her Pail.

Outagamie County, Wisconsin

A Wisconsin drive-in, 1968

The first patented drive-in theater opened in Camden, New Jersey, in 1933, and the form boomed after the Second World War, when thousands were built on the edges of towns across the country; Wisconsin had about eighty at its height. Most ran only in the warm months, nightly through Labor Day and on weekends after it until the cold. Until xenon bulbs replaced them, projectors used carbon arc lamps, which burned two carbon rods down in a bright, hot arc and had to be tended by hand. A feature came on reels of about twenty minutes each, run on two projectors in turn; the projectionist watched for the small cue marks in the upper right corner of the frame, the first to start the second machine and the second, about seven seconds later, to switch to it.

The Fox River valley around Appleton and Kaukauna was paper country, its mills lined along the river's fall to Green Bay, and Wisconsin had led the country in fur farming since before the war, as it still leads in mink. Walt Kuehl's division, the 32nd Infantry Division, the "Red Arrow," was formed from Wisconsin and Michigan National Guard units and fought at Buna in New Guinea and on Leyte and Luzon; it logged more days in combat than any other American division in the war. *Yours, Mine and Ours,* with Lucille Ball and Henry Fonda, opened in April 1968 and was one of the year's biggest hits.

After the story of Nephew Saṅgharakkhita from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 37). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3.5

The Weathervane

Just stand right still, and steady yourself, I know that my Redeemer lives.
— "I Know That My Redeemer Lives," Fisk Jubilee Singers

Peace, and this is how it was told, at the long table on Macon Street.

I. Leftovers

Sayville, Long Island · August 1930

Lemuel Pryor played piano in a cellar on West 133rd Street from midnight until the milk wagons, for two dollars and whatever went into the cigar box on the lid. The cellar had no name on the door. People called it the Coal Hole, because that was what it had been, and the gin came down the steps in teapots and went out to the tables in cups. Lem had a left hand that could walk a tenth all night without looking, and a right hand that got bored and wandered, and between the two of them he made enough to pay half the rent on two rooms over an undertaker on 131st Street, where he lived with his wife Ida and her mother.

Ida did day work in the Bronx. Her mother, Mrs. Odessa Bynum, did nothing, and did it from a cot in the front room, where she could see the door.

In August Ida's cousin Bernice, who was seventeen, went out to Sayville on the train to the man the papers called God and did not come back. She sent a postcard with a picture of the bay on it. It said she was well and happy and fed, and it was signed with a name none of them knew. Mrs. Bynum read it twice and held it out to Lem with two fingers.

You go get her. You're the only man in this house, and you sleep all day anyhow.

He changed at Jamaica and rode out past the last of the city into potato fields and scrub oak and little towns with white churches, and got down at Sayville a little after noon. Nobody had to tell him the way. A bus with Newark on its sign was parked on Macon Street with its doors open, and there were cars on both sides of the road, and people walking toward the house in their good clothes, colored and white together, as if it were Easter. The house was a big frame house with a porch and a lawn. On the porch rail somebody had painted a sign: *NOTICE—Smoking—Intoxicating Liquors—Profane Language—Strictly Prohibited.*

He found Bernice in the side yard with three other women in white aprons, snapping beans into a washtub. Her face had filled out. She looked up at him and smiled the way you smile at a man selling something.

Peace, Lemuel.

He said what Mrs. Bynum had told him to say. She went on snapping beans. He said it again, some of it. One of the other women hummed. Bernice told him she was called Busy Bee now, and that she had a bed with a white spread and her own hook for her dress, and a job three days a week minding a doctor's children on the Montauk Highway, and that she owed nobody a cent, and that she had not been hungry once since she came. Then she held up a bean and snapped it.

He stood there a while. He thought about the train back, and about telling Mrs. Bynum. Then he let it be. She looked fine. She looked better than any of them.

He had not eaten since a fish sandwich at five that morning. He went around to the kitchen door, the way he would have gone to any kitchen door, and took his hat off.

There was a small old woman at the sink, very dark, with her sleeves pushed up and her hair under a white cloth. Behind her, on a long board laid across two barrels, were the platters that had come back from the noon table. Fried chicken. A ham with the bone showing. Rice and gravy. Collards. Candied yams with the syrup gone hard at the edges. A bowl of sliced tomatoes. Light rolls under a cloth. Three pies with pieces gone, sweet potato and apple and something with a lattice.

She looked at him the way you look at weather.

Peace, she said. *Get a plate.*

He ate standing up, then sitting on an upturned crate, then standing again to reach the pie. When he was done he drank two dippers of water and washed his hands at her sink, and she moved over for him without being asked.

Was somebody married here today?

No.

Somebody's funeral?

No, baby. It's Tuesday.

He stood with his wet hands held out in front of him. He thought about the Coal Hole at four in the morning, the smoke so thick the bulb was a brown moon, a drunk from Sugar Hill leaning on the lid asking for the same tune for the fifth time, and the fish sandwich after, and the stairs over the undertaker's. He played all night six nights a week and had never once sat down to a table like the one that had been cleared from that room. These people ate like a wedding on a Tuesday.

What does a man have to do, he said, *to stay?*

She told him. She did not make it sound like much. No liquor. No tobacco. No cursing. No man with a woman, in this house or out of it, not even his own wife. Work if there was work. Pay cash and owe nobody. Take the name that came to him, if one came.

He thought of Ida, asleep when he came in and gone when he woke up. He thought of Mrs. Bynum's cot by the door. He had been married two years and could count on his hands the nights the two rooms had been quiet.

I can do that, he said.

She looked at him a long time over the sink. Then she dried her hands and took him up the back stairs herself and showed him a cot in the long room under the roof where the men slept, and a nail for his coat.

II. The Ledger

Sayville and Harlem · autumn 1930 to autumn 1931

THE KITCHEN WOMEN CALLED HER SISTER STILL WATER. Nobody used whatever name she had come up from Tennessee with, and nobody asked it.

There was an upright piano in the front parlor that nobody played well, and the second evening Lem sat down at it, and after that the house had a piano player. He played at the banquets. They sang Mission songs and the old songs, and he put a walking bass under all of them, and the people at the long table rose one after another to testify and sat down again shining. At the head of the table sat a small bald man in a good suit, and the platters went down the table from him, and he was God to everybody in the room. Lem never spoke to him. He watched him from the piano bench, at a distance, the way you would watch weather coming across a bay.

In ten days his collar would not close. In three weeks he had let out the back seam of his only suit.

Then one morning, carrying a stack of plates, he thought: what kind of a man eats at another man's table for nothing? A man ought to be paid for his hands. He thought of the Coal Hole, and the cigar box, and of Ida turning over in the bed. He took his coat off the nail and walked to the station.

That winter the Coal Hole cut him to a dollar a night. The rent man came on Mondays. Ida came home from the Bronx with her feet swollen and her pay docked, because women stood on corners up there now and let housewives pick them out by the hour, and the price went down every week. Lem ate what there was, which was beans and day-old bread and coffee boiled twice, and in a month his suit hung on him like a borrowed one. Mrs. Bynum watched him from the cot and said things to the ceiling.

So he went back.

In the front hall at Macon Street there was a ledger on a little table where the people who came to stay wrote their names. A big gentle man called Brother Glad Tidings kept it. The first time, Lem had written

Lemuel Pryor on a clean line and Brother Glad Tidings had blotted it. The second time, Brother Glad Tidings found the old line, drew a pen through it, and had him write it again underneath. The third time he did the same, more slowly. They took him back each time because he played, and because he carried and washed and swept without being asked, and because there was nobody else who could make that piano sound like that.

Behind the house, two lots down, there was a carriage barn with an iron rooster on the ridge, standing on an arrow, and the rooster turned with every wind that came up off the bay. One of the young men at the table pointed it out to the others the fourth time Lem came up the walk with his cardboard suitcase, and after that they called him Brother Weathervane. They did not say it unkindly. They said it the way you name a mule for what it does.

In the spring, during one of his times at home, Ida found she was going to have a baby. She told him on the stoop, without much expression, as if she were telling him the price of something. He held her a long time, and was home a whole month, and then one morning he woke up thinking about pie. Mrs. Bynum, from the cot, said: *A man with a baby coming.* He took his coat.

In May a deputy came to Macon Street and arrested God for disturbing the peace, and God paid his own bail in cash and came back to the head of the table, and the neighbors went on writing to the papers. In June Lem went home. In August he came back. By the fall his name stood six times in Brother Glad Tidings' ledger, five of them with a line through it, one under another, down the margin of the page.

III. The Kitchenette

West 131st Street, Harlem · a Saturday in November 1931

He came up from the Coal Hole at a quarter to seven in the morning with eighty cents in his pocket and his mind made up. He would get his good shirt and his razor and be on the eight-something out

of Penn Station, and he would be at Macon Street by the noon table. He had told nobody. He never did.

Downstairs, through the undertaker's front window, he could see a man laid out on a board under a sheet, waiting for his people, with only his face showing, the mouth a little open. Lem looked at him the way you look at anything in a window and went on up.

The bedroom had one window on the airshaft and the light that came down it was gray. Ida was asleep on her back. She was seven months along and she could not sleep any other way now. The quilt had slid off her onto the floor, and the strap of her slip had come down, and the slip had worked up around her middle so that the great round of her belly stood up out of it, bare. Her mouth was open. She was snoring with a catch at the end of each breath, and a wet line ran from the corner of her mouth into the pillow, and her hands lay at her sides palm up.

He stood in the door with his hat in his hand.

He had seen her asleep a thousand times. He had never seen her. In that light she was the man downstairs. She was the man downstairs and every man the undertaker had ever laid on his board, and his own grandmother in Clarksville with a nickel on each eye, and himself, some morning, in some gray light, with his mouth open just like that. Everything in the room was going there. The bed, the quilt on the floor, the baby, the hand he was holding his hat with.

His grandmother used to sing a song at the washpot. He had not thought of it in years. *Just watch that sun, and see how it runs.* He heard it now in her voice, flat and slow, the way she sang it with her arms in the water.

He thought: and this is what I kept coming back for.

He did not get the shirt. He took his Sayville coat down off the hook behind the door, the dark one the brothers had given him, and went out through the front room with it over his arm, and down the stairs pulling it on, and was buttoning it as he passed the undertaker's window, and did not look in.

Mrs. Bynum had seen him go. She had seen him come in four minutes before, and she had heard nothing in the bedroom, no drawer, no voices.

She got up off the cot in her wrapper and went and looked in at her daughter, and she understood all of it at once, the way she generally did.

She took Ida by the shoulder and shook her.

Get up. Your husband just saw you sleeping with your mouth open and lit out of here like the house was afire. He had on that coat. You won't have that one back.

Ida opened her eyes, and wiped her mouth with the back of her wrist, and found the quilt with one hand and pulled it up.

Mama, go on, she said. *He'll be back by Thursday.*

She turned over toward the wall, which took her some time, and went back to sleep.

IV. The Montauk Train

Long Island Rail Road · the same morning

He paid his fare with the eighty cents and a dollar he kept folded in his shoe. He sat by a window in a car that smelled of wet wool, with his hat on his knees, and the wheels found the rail joints and kept time on them, and under the time he heard the song.

Just watch that sun, and see how it runs.

He said it under his breath. He said it at Jamaica, changing trains, and on the platform, and again when the city fell away behind and the flat country opened out, brown fields with the potatoes up and gone, crows walking the furrows, a boy on a fence. Each thing the window gave him, it took away. A white church. A gas station with one pump. A woman taking in a wash with the wind trying to have it. A dog that ran beside the train and gave up. He watched them come and go, and he said the line, and every one of them went exactly the way the man downstairs had gone and Ida was going and he was going. None of it would hold still. None of it was ever going to.

Somewhere past Babylon, where a creek ran down through the marsh grass, he caught a long look at the bay, flat and pewter-colored, with a few oyster boats out on it and the long low line of the beach beyond.

Something in him that had been swinging for a year and a half, in every wind, came around and stopped.

Nobody stopped it. It came to rest the way a pendulum does when nobody pushes it anymore. He sat there with his hat on his knees. The car rocked. The sun came out on the bay. He did not want anything from it. It was the first time he could remember not wanting anything from anything.

At Sayville he walked up Macon Street in the cold sun with his coat buttoned to the neck and nothing in his hands. The rooster on the carriage barn was swinging back and forth on its arrow, unable to decide about the wind. He looked at it and did not mind it.

Brother Glad Tidings met him in the front hall with the ledger already open, and did not hand him the pen.

No, he said. *Brother, no. Not this time.*

He turned the book around so Lem could see. Down the margin of the page the name stood six times, five times struck, and where the pen had gone over and over the same place the paper had worn through. You could see the floor through it.

Look at that. We've written you in so many times there's a hole in the book. What do you want to come in for? You'll be gone by Thursday.

Just this once, Lem said.

Brother Glad Tidings looked at him. Behind him in the parlor somebody was trying to pick out a hymn on the upright with one finger, and missing, and starting again.

Sister Still Water came through from the kitchen with flour to her elbows. She looked at Lem a moment, the way she had looked at him over the sink fifteen months before. Then she took the pen out of Brother Glad Tidings' hand, turned past the page with the hole in it to a clean one, and held the pen out.

He wrote his name. She blotted it with the side of her floury hand.

V. Stand Still

Macon Street · that week

He played for the noon table and the evening table. He washed. He swept the long room under the roof. In the evenings when the house was quiet he sat on the back step and watched the light go off the bay, and that was all he did with the evenings. By Wednesday the brothers had started to look at him sideways. By Friday they had started to talk.

They meant no harm by it. At the end of the evening table one of the young ones leaned down the board toward him.

Brother Weathervane. Which way is the wind today?

They laughed. Lem laughed with them.

You'll let us know when you're fixing to go, said another. *You've been here a long while this time. It's nearly a week.*

I'm not going, Lem said.

Not till Thursday.

When I was hooked to all that, Lem said, *I went. I'm not hooked to it. I don't have anyplace to go.*

He said it plainly, the way he would say what key a song was in, and went back to his pie. The young men looked at each other. Later that night three of them went into the kitchen, where Sister Still Water was setting the bread to rise for the morning under clean flour sacks, and Brother Glad Tidings went with them because he kept the book.

Sister. You know what Brother Weathervane is saying now? He says he's through. He says he's got no place to go.

He's telling a story, said another. *He's got a wife in Harlem with a baby coming. He'll be gone by Thursday. He always is.*

She went on folding the sacks over the bread. When she was done she wiped her hands.

When that boy didn't have his mind fixed, she said, *he came and he went. He couldn't learn anything. He wasn't ever here long enough to learn it. Now he's set down. He's through with all that, the good and the bad both. You leave him be.*

Then, because they were still standing there, she sang them a verse of an old song, low, the way you would sing to a child who was nearly asleep. It was the same song. It had gone all over Tennessee the year she was a girl, after the singers came back from the North with it.

> *Just stand right still, and steady yourself, I know that my Redeemer lives.*
>
> *Just watch that sun, and see how it runs, I know that my Redeemer lives.*
> *Oh, don't let it catch you with your work undone, I know that my Redeemer lives.*
>
> *— "I Know That My Redeemer Lives," in J. B. T. Marsh, The Story of the Jubilee Singers, Including Their Songs (1898)*

Lem heard it through the wall, from the back step, where he was sitting in the dark. He knew all the words. He had always known them.

VI. The Wagons

Macon Street · Sunday, November 15, 1931

That Sunday the people came out from Harlem and Newark and Brooklyn and the towns around in buses and cars and on foot from the station, and there were three thousand of them in the house and on the porch and on the lawn and standing in the road, and the singing went on into the night. A few days before, the white people of Sayville had held a meeting at which they said they had nothing against colored people. They had said other things too.

A little before midnight the police came, from Sayville and the towns nearby, with state troopers behind them, and men from the town who were neither. They stood at the edge of the lawn with their lights and said the meeting would disperse in fifteen minutes. The singing did not stop. In the parlor Lem kept on playing.

When the fifteen minutes were up they came in. They took seventy-eight people, colored and white, out of the house and off the porch and

put them in wagons and cars to go to the courthouse. Some of the women cried. Some of the young men shouted. One of the brothers who had laughed at the table that week stood on the porch steps with his fists shut and his whole face shaking.

Lem closed the lid of the piano. He got up and put on his coat and went out between two troopers, and when one of them took his arm he let him take it. There was nothing the man could take from him. He did not have anything. He stood in the back of the wagon with the brothers pressed around him in the dark, and he could feel the boy with the shaking face against his shoulder, and he began to sing the Daniel verse, not loud.

Oh, Daniel in the lion's den, I know that my Redeemer lives.

The boy did not sing. But after a while he stopped shaking.

In the morning forty-six of them pleaded guilty and paid five dollars apiece. God paid his fine with a five-hundred-dollar bill, and the court could not make change for it, and that was the story all the way back to Harlem by night. Lem had nothing. Sister Still Water paid his five dollars out of the pocket of her apron, from a roll of ones that smelled of yeast.

VII. Seed Peas

The kitchen on Macon Street · that night

THEY SAT IN THE KITCHEN AFTERWARD, THE ONES WHO HAD come back, too tired to go up. Somebody had put coffee on.

The young men talked about Brother Weathervane, who had gone up to bed. They did not call him that now. They talked about him the way you talk about a man who has come through a fever. Seven times, one of them said. Seven times in the book. What kind of a hook has a man got in him, that it takes seven times to pull it out?

Sister Still Water was at the board with her back to them, cutting lard into flour with two knives.

That's not much of a hook, she said. *I knew a woman it took seven times for a hoe.*

They waited. She went on cutting.

She came up from Tennessee, she said, *with a hoe with the edge gone off it and a snuff can of crowder peas her mother saved, for seed. She got a little patch in a lot behind a church on Lenox Avenue, where the ground was all brickbats, and she grew her peas. Then she came out here to Father. And come the spring she thought, who's going to plant my peas? I can't let my peas go. So she went back and planted them. And she picked them in August, and she saved a can of them for seed, and she came back out here. And come the spring she thought about those peas.*

Seven times?

Seven times. A dull hoe and a snuff can of peas. The seventh time she said, I know what's doing this. So she took the hoe and the can and walked out on the bridge at 145th Street, over the river. And she tied the can to the end of the hoe handle with her head-rag, so it would sink. And she thought, if I see where it goes in, I'll be down there in the mud after it by dark. So she shut her eyes. And she swung it around her head three times and let it go. And she turned her back so she wouldn't see it hit, and she hollered out, I hit! I hit! I hit!

The young men laughed. In Harlem nobody hollered that on a bridge.

There was a man stopped on that bridge in a long car, she said. *A banker. A policy man. He had just run another man's runners off his streets that morning, and he was feeling like a king. And the one thing a policy banker does not like to hear is somebody hollering I hit. So he got out of his car in his good coat and came over to her and he said, Woman, what did you hit? Because I didn't pay anybody today.*

What did she tell him?

She said, You run the other man off this morning. And you have to run him off again tomorrow, and the day after, as long as you live. That's the kind you hit. I hit the one you only have to hit once. And she told him what it was.

She set down the knives.

The people on the bridge said that while she was talking she sat down. There wasn't anything there to sit on. She sat on the air a foot above the rail, over the river, with her hands in her lap, like it was a kitchen chair. I don't know about that. That's what they said.

And the banker?

He shut up his bank that week and came out here with all his runners behind him in a line. And the man from the other streets came over to take his territory, and found the shop empty and the books burned, and he stood in there a while, and then he came too. Seven of them, before it was done. For a while there you couldn't get a number down in four blocks of Harlem. People said the bankers had all gone to Sayville to get fat.

The young men were laughing again, but quietly now, and looking at her.

Who was she? one of them said. *The woman with the hoe.*

Sister Still Water picked up her two knives and went back to the lard.

Same old fool as always, she said. *Go to bed.*

• • •

In the morning there was a wind off the bay. Lem was at the upright in the front parlor early, before the table, running his left hand down the keys to warm it, a tenth and back, a tenth and back. Out the window, two lots down, the iron rooster on the carriage barn swung east and west and east again on its arrow. He could see it from the bench if he turned his head. He did not turn his head.

Background

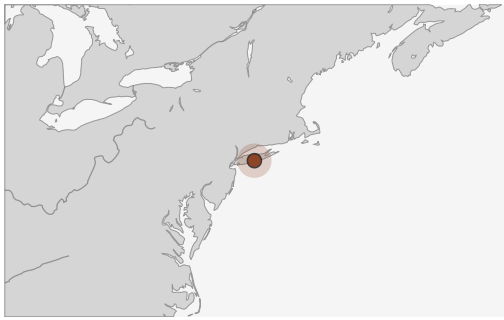
The verses

> *If a man's thoughts are unsteady, if he does not know the true law, if his peace of mind is troubled, his knowledge will never be perfect.*
>
> Dhammapada 38, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If a man's thoughts are not dissipated, if his mind is not perplexed, if he has ceased to think of good or evil, then there is no fear for him while he is watchful.*
>
> Dhammapada 39, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young man out looking for a lost ox stops at a monastery, is fed the monks' leftovers, and decides to become a monk for the food. He grows fat, goes home, grows thin, and comes back, six times, until the monks call him Cittahattha, "led by his mind." The seventh time, coming in from the fields, he sees his pregnant

wife asleep with her mouth open and her clothes fallen away, and she looks to him like a corpse. He runs from the house tying his robe on as he goes, while his mother-in-law wakes her daughter to tell her he is gone for good, and the wife says he will be back in a few days. On the road, repeating that all things pass, he reaches the first stage of awakening; the monks, who say his head is "like a grindstone" from so many shavings, take him back one last time, and soon he is an arahat. When he says he has no more desire to leave, they call it a lie, and the Buddha answers with these verses. Afterward he tells how, in a past life, he himself went forth and came back six times for the sake of a blunt spade and half a pot of seed beans, until he threw them into the Ganges with his eyes shut and cried "I have conquered!", a cry overheard by a king just home from war, who renounced his throne, followed by six more kings. Read the full commentary story, or about the Jātaka tales, where the story of the wise Kuddāla is told.



Sayville, Long Island, New York

Sayville and Harlem, 1931

About 1919 the preacher known as Father Divine settled with a small group of followers in a house at 72 Macon Street in Sayville, on the south shore of Long Island. During the Depression his free banquets drew crowds by bus and car from Harlem, Newark and elsewhere, as many as three thousand at a time by 1931, colored and white at the same table. Followers lived communally under strict rules against liquor, tobacco, profanity and sex, even within marriage, and many took new spiritual names; the movement found jobs for them, often in domestic work. Neighbors complained of the noise and the traffic. Father Divine was arrested for disturbing the peace in May 1931, and on the night of November 15, after a town meeting, police and state troopers broke up a meeting at the house and arrested seventy-eight people, fifteen of them white. Forty-six pleaded guilty and paid five-dollar fines; Father Divine, by the familiar story, paid with a five-hundred-dollar bill. His trial the next spring before Judge Lewis J. Smith ended in the maximum sentence, and the judge's sudden death four days later became a famous legend. The movement soon moved its center to Harlem as the International Peace Mission movement.

In Harlem, the block of West 133rd Street between Lenox and Seventh Avenues was lined with Prohibition speakeasies and clubs, where stride pianists played through the night. The spiritual Sister Still Water sings, "I Know That My Redeemer Lives," was printed among the songs of the Fisk Jubilee Singers, the Nashville student choir whose tours from 1871 onward first brought the spirituals to concert audiences in the North and in Europe. The text quoted here follows the 1898 London edition of J. B. T. Marsh's *The Story of the Jubilee Singers, Including Their Songs*; the song appears in the earlier editions as well.

After the story of Cittahattha from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 38 and 39). The original. Spiritual from J. B. T. Marsh, *The Story of the Jubilee Singers, Including Their Songs* (1898). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3.6

The Water Pot

Either seen or which are not seen, and which live far (or) near, either born or seeking birth, may all creatures be happy-minded.
— Sutta Nipāta 146, tr. V. Fausböll (1881)

Hearing, hearing, it was heard like this, on the hill in Barre.

I. The Living Room

Washington, D.C. · summer 1976

Daw Tin Hla taught on Saturday mornings in her son's apartment off Connecticut Avenue, with the sofa pushed against the wall and the air conditioner going in the window like an outboard motor. She was sixty-eight, a widow from Rangoon, and she had sat long retreats at the meditation center there in the fifties, before her husband's posting brought them to Washington and then his heart gave out and left her in it. Her son was an economist at the World Bank and was gone by seven. On the bookshelf were a small brass Buddha, a little paper flag in stripes of blue, yellow, red, white and pink, and a row of her husband's English books from the university, gone soft in the heat of two countries.

Out on the balcony, eleven floors up, she kept a round clay water pot on an iron stand with a lid and a tin dipper, the way people did along the roads at home, so that anyone passing could drink. Nobody passed eleven floors up. She filled it every morning anyway.

Her students that summer were four young Americans who had found her through a notice on the board at a health food store in Takoma Park. Nora Kessel catalogued books at the Library of Congress and had not been able to sleep through a night since college. Bev Tuttle threw pots in a co-op studio on Carroll Avenue and had come, at first, mostly to look at

the water pot on the balcony. Ellis Washington was in his second year of law school at Georgetown and was the only one of them who could sit still for an hour on the first try, which annoyed the others. Dewey Oakes had come home from Quang Tri in 1969 and hung drywall, and sat in the back by the door.

She taught them to note. Rising, falling, at the belly. Hearing, hearing, when the air conditioner kicked on. Wanting, wanting, at the smell of the mohinga she had going in the kitchen for afterward, fish broth and lemongrass and noodles. She said very little else. When Ellis asked her a long question about the self, she said, *Note it,* and went to stir the soup.

In August she told them that some young Americans, who had sat in Burma and India, had bought an old Catholic house in Massachusetts for meditation, and were holding a three-month course there in the fall, the way it was done at home in the rains. *Go and sit the three months,* she said. *All of you. Here you are only playing.*

II. The Fathers' House

Barre, Massachusetts · September

They went up in Dewey's Volkswagen bus with their cushions and their sleeping bags and a cooler of Bev's granola, nine hours with the engine whining up every hill, and came into Barre in the late afternoon, a town of white houses around a long green common, with dairy farms going off on every side into the hills. They stopped at a luncheonette on the common because Ellis was hungry, and the woman behind the counter, a Mrs. Lacasse, gave them coffee and pie and looked at their cushions.

Where are you kids headed?

Somewhere quiet, Nora said, which was what Daw Tin Hla had told them to say.

Well, you found it. When she understood they were going up the hill to the old novitiate for three months, she put down the coffee pot. *The whole three months? Without talking?* She thought about that. *My aunt cleaned for the Fathers up there twenty years. That was a lot of house for a few priests. You*

stay the three months, and I'll tell you what. I'll keep my Roland out of those woods this deer season. He'll hate it. She did not charge them for the pie.

The house stood at the top of a long drive in eighty acres of oak and pine and old pasture, a great old house that the Blessed Sacrament novitiate had kept since just after the war, with beds for a hundred and only eighteen men and one novice left in it at the end. The young teachers who had bought it the year before had made the chapel into the meditation hall and the long room beside it into a walking room, where two stained-glass windows of Christ still looked down on people pacing very slowly back and forth beneath them. There was a bowling alley in the basement that nobody had the heart to take out. There were about thirty yogis for the three months. Each was given a narrow room in what had been a novice's cell, and a yogi job. Nora's was the kitchen, a great tiled novitiate kitchen with steel sinks big enough to bathe in and pots you could stand a child in, where she chopped carrots and onions every morning for thirty people and washed the oatmeal pot after breakfast, noting, lifting, scrubbing, rinsing.

The teachers gave talks in the evening from a low platform where the altar had been, and interviews in the afternoon. The four from Washington sat and walked and noted, and for two weeks it was hard in the ordinary ways: the knees, the boredom, the radiators that clanged like hammers when the oil burner came on, which the teachers said to take for a bell.

• • •

What had lived in the trees on that hill had lived there a long time, longer than the Fathers or the farmers before them, and it had got along with the Fathers well enough. The Fathers had been few and had kept mostly to the house, praying in the chapel day and night in turns, and the woods had been left to the ones who lived in them, with their families, in the high branches of the oaks.

Now thirty people came out of the house every hour of the day and walked slowly in the woods, under the oaks, lifting one foot and placing it, looking at nothing, and sat on the ground among the roots for hours,

and did not leave. It did not seem right to the ones in the trees to live over the heads of such people. So they came down out of the branches, with their families, and sat on the ground in the dark under the pines, and said to one another, *They'll be gone in the morning.* In the morning the thirty went into the house for breakfast, and came out again. *Someone has fed them,* the ones on the ground said. *Tomorrow they'll go.* They sat on the ground in the cold like that for two weeks.

Then they saw that these people meant to stay the whole three months, and that they themselves would be sitting on the frozen ground with their children until Christmas, and they put their heads together to see how the people might be got rid of.

III. Seeing, Seeing

Barre · late September and October

DEWEY SAW IT FIRST, AT FOUR IN THE MORNING, AT THE FAR end of the third-floor corridor where the night light was: a man in a long black cassock standing by the radiator with his hands folded, and above the white collar nothing at all. Dewey had seen a good many things in Quang Tri Province and did not scream. He noted it. *Seeing, seeing.* It did not go away when he noted it. He went back into his cell and sat on the bed until the wake-up bell with his back against the wall.

Ellis saw a head. It was in the walking room in the afternoon, a young man's head, pale, with its hair combed wet, hanging in the air at the far end of the room under one of the windows of Christ, and looking at him with great patience, and nothing under it. He turned at the end of his lane as he had been taught, *turning, turning,* and when he came back it was still there, and when he came back the next time it was nearer.

Bev heard the voices. In the night, under the floor, men's voices murmuring together in a language she did not know, and then the long rumble of a ball down the lane in the bowling alley and the crash of pins, over and over, when everyone in the house was asleep and the basement door was locked. *Hearing, hearing.*

Nora saw nothing. But she woke every night at three with the certainty that someone was standing just inside her door looking at her, and lay rigid until dawn noting *afraid, afraid,* and in the kitchen in the mornings her hands shook so that she cut herself twice on the onion knife.

And everyone got sick. All through the house that October people sneezed and coughed, so that the evening talks went on over a steady sound like rain on a roof, and boxes of tissues stood at the ends of the rows of cushions, and the teachers blamed the old oil burners and the dust in the radiators and the change of season. The four from Washington were the worst. Bev lost her voice entirely, which on a silent retreat should not have mattered, and somehow did.

They met behind the barn, which was against the rules, on a cold bright afternoon with the maples gone red down the hill, and whispered.

I've been coughing for nine days.

There's a man with no head on the third floor.

There's a head with no man in the walking room.

Bev wrote on the back of her hand with a ballpoint: *bowling.*

This place is no good for us, said Dewey, and the others were relieved that somebody had said it. *Let's go home to Daw Tin Hla.*

They left a note for the teachers on the kitchen table, under the salt, and drove south through the night with the heater on and the windows fogging and all four of them coughing, and did not talk about the man or the head or the bowling, and were in Washington by morning.

IV. The Weapon

Washington · October

Daw Tin Hla opened the door in her housecoat and looked at the four of them on the mat, with their sleeping bags and their red noses, and stood aside to let them in. She did not seem surprised. She made tea. She let them tell it, all of it, the cassock and the head and the pins and the three o'clock door, and she listened with her hands in her lap the way she listened to the rain.

You could not stay there?

No, Nora said. *We couldn't.*

Of course there are beings there, said Daw Tin Hla. *Tree spirits. Nats. Thirty years they had that hill with only a few quiet priests. Now you come and walk under their houses all day long and sit on their doorsteps. They don't like it. Would you?* She drank her tea. *You must go back.*

We can't, said Dewey.

The first time you went with nothing in your hands. This time you will take a weapon.

Dewey, who had carried an M16 for thirteen months and had not touched a gun since, looked at her for a long moment. *What kind of weapon?*

She went to the bookshelf and took down one of her husband's soft old books, a thick one in dark blue cloth, and found the page without looking for it. She said that this had happened before, a long time ago, to some monks who went to sit the rains in a forest, and the Buddha had sent them back with this. She said it to them first in Pāli, the way it was chanted at home, so that the sound would be in them, and then she read it out of the old book in English, slowly, all of it, while the air conditioner rattled in the window and the traffic went by on Connecticut Avenue eleven floors down.

> *Whatever living beings there are, either feeble or strong, all either long or great, middle-sized, short, small or large,*
>
> *Either seen or which are not seen, and which live far (or) near, either born or seeking birth, may all creatures be happy-minded.*
>
> *— Sutta Nipāta 145–146 (Mettasutta), tr. V. Fausböll (1881)*

Seen or not seen, she said. *That is them too. Learn it. When you get there, stop at the bottom of the drive and say it all the way through, the four of you, before you go up to the house. Then go in.*

They stayed three days. They learned it, the Pāli by sound and the English by heart, sitting on her son's carpet with their tea, and Bev, whose voice had come back, practiced the hard words on the balcony beside the water pot. On the third morning Daw Tin Hla gave them a bag of rice

and a jar of fish paste for the kitchen, which Nora was fairly sure the teachers in Barre would not allow, and sent them north.

V. The Driveway

Barre · the end of October to December

Dewey stopped the bus at the bottom of the long drive at dusk and turned off the engine. The four of them got out and stood in the gravel in the cold, facing up the hill toward the dark woods and the lit windows of the house, and said it, the Pāli and then the English, all the way through, not very loudly. Ellis knew it best and kept the time. Their breath went up white. A car went by on the road behind them and slowed down to look and went on. When they finished, nothing happened that any of them could point to. They got back in the bus and drove up.

Their sleeping bags were on their beds when they came in. None of them had carried them up. Nobody in the office knew anything about it.

Then it was quiet. It is the thing everyone who sat that course remembers about the second half of it: how quiet that house became. The radiators still clanged when the burner came on, but not in the night. The bowling alley was silent. Nobody saw a head anywhere. The coughing in the hall thinned out over a week and stopped. In the kitchen at five in the morning Nora found the oatmeal pot from the night before already scoured and turned upside down on the drainboard, though she had left it to soak, and the woodbox by the old range was full, and the onions for the soup were peeled and lying in a row like eggs. She asked the cook. The cook said she had thought it was Nora.

Dewey, who sat the night watch in the hall from two to four because he was awake anyway, said that some nights there were figures standing at every door of the old chapel, tall and still, facing outward, the way ushers stand at the back of a church during the prayers. He said it plainly, months afterward, over coffee at the luncheonette, and nobody laughed at him. Nora woke one night at three, as she always had, and found her

feet warm, warm right through, as if somebody had been holding them in both hands, and went back to sleep.

Down the hill Roland Lacasse kept out of the woods for the whole shotgun season and complained about it at the luncheonette every morning.

So they sat. They sat in the old chapel and walked under the stained-glass Christ and noted, and in the kitchen Nora washed the great pots, and in the long hours the body became what she was sitting with. Daw Tin Hla had told them, at the end, what the monks in the forest had looked at. Nora looked at it in the kitchen with her hands in the dishwater: a pot. A clay pot, like the one on the balcony eleven floors up, cool on the outside and sweating a little, good for carrying water, and fired thin, and cracking. Every pot she lifted out of the suds she felt it in her own arms, the weight and the thinness. Bev, who had pulled a thousand pots out of a kiln and seen a third of them come out split, said later that she had thought the same thing at the same hour, sitting in the hall. Bev said it was the plainest thing she had ever understood. It did not frighten her.

On a Saturday morning in December, at the first sitting, before light, the four of them were sitting together near the back of the hall when Daw Tin Hla came and sat down on the floor in front of them.

She was in the white blouse and the dark longyi she wore to teach, with her hands folded in her lap. She sat facing them, close enough to touch, and there was light coming off her in stripes of color, blue and yellow and red and white and pink and all of them run together at the edge, the colors of the little paper flag on her bookshelf, so that the floorboards around her were lit with them and the frost on the dark window behind her showed every color. The people sitting near them saw it. Some of them wrote it down afterward and some of them told it at dinner tables for forty years, and they told it the same way.

It is so, she said, looking at the four of them. *This body is a clay pot. Make the mind a fort. Fight with what you have seen, and when you have won, guard it. Don't move in anywhere.*

Then she was not there, and the floor was dark again, and the radiators clanged. The four of them sat on in the hall until the bell for break-

fast and some time after it. The people who were there say that those four came out of the old chapel that morning finished with something, and walked down the hall to the dining room the way people walk out of a hospital after a long time, carefully, looking at everything, and that was all anyone could say about it. Nora went into the kitchen and put on her apron. The oatmeal pot was soaking. She washed it.

Daw Tin Hla's son said, when they asked him at Christmas, that his mother had been at home that Saturday morning with the door of her room shut, as she was every Saturday morning, and had come out at eight and made mohinga.

VI. The Pot

Barre · spring 1977

In April Bev drove up from Washington alone, with a round clay pot in a box of straw on the seat beside her. She had thrown it on the wheel on Carroll Avenue and fired it thin, the way Daw Tin Hla had told her the potters did at home. She set it on a flat stone at the bottom of the long drive, where the four of them had stood in the gravel and said the words, and filled it from the hose at the house, and put a lid on it and hung a tin dipper on its rim. She did not ask anyone's permission.

People drank from it. The mailman, the oil truck driver, yogis going down to the road to stretch their legs, a boy on a bicycle, Mrs. Lacasse once, on a Sunday, out for a drive with Roland. Somebody at the house filled it every morning. Nobody could ever say who.

It lasted until the first hard freeze the next November. In the morning it stood on the stone split down one side, with a fan of ice standing in the crack and the dipper still hanging from the rim, and it was cool to the touch, and it held nothing, and it was a good pot.

Background

The verse

> *Knowing that this body is (fragile) like a jar, and making this thought firm like a fortress, one should attack Mara (the tempter) with the weapon of knowledge, one should watch him when conquered, and should never rest.*
>
> Dhammapada 40, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred monks take a meditation subject from the Buddha and travel a hundred leagues to a village, whose people feed them and ask them to spend the three months of the rains in a nearby forest grove. The tree spirits there, unwilling to live above the monks' heads, come down with their families and sit on the ground waiting for them to leave; when the monks stay, the spirits show them headless bodies and bodiless heads, make them hear voices, and afflict them with sneezing and coughing until the monks flee back to the Buddha. He sends them back with a "weapon," the Discourse on Loving-Kindness, to be recited outside the grove before they enter. The spirits welcome them, carry their bowls, rub their hands and feet, and stand guard. Contemplating the body as fragile as a potter's jar, the monks develop insight, and the Buddha, though a hundred leagues away, appears before them sending out six-colored rays and speaks the verse; all of them reach awakening. This is the traditional origin story of the Karaniya Metta Sutta. Read the full commentary story.

Barre, Massachusetts

Barre, *1976*

In 1975 the young teachers Joseph Goldstein, Sharon Salzberg, Jack Kornfield and Jacqueline Schwartz, who had trained in Burma, Thailand and India, bought a former Catholic novitiate in Barre, Massachusetts, for $150,000. The Insight Meditation Society opened there on February 14, 1976. The house had been the Blessed Sacrament novitiate since 1946. The old chapel became the meditation hall, stained

glass of Christ stayed in the walking room, and a bowling alley stayed in the basement; early yogis remember the clanging radiators of the old oil-fired heat as the house's first mindfulness bells (IMS at 50; a profile of the founding). Its three-month retreat, modeled on the monastic rains retreat, was first held in Barre that year, with about thirty people. The practice was largely the noting method of the Burmese teacher Mahasi Sayadaw, in which the meditator silently labels each experience as it arises: rising, falling, hearing, seeing.

In Burma, belief in nats, spirits of trees, places and households, sits alongside Theravada practice, and the Metta Sutta is among the protective discourses chanted to keep peace with them. The six colors that the Buddha's body is said to have emitted are the colors of the Buddhist flag, designed in Colombo in 1885; in Burma its orange stripe is read as pink. Daw Tin Hla, her students, the Lacasses and all the events at Barre in this story are invented.

After the story of the five hundred monks with insight from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 40). The original. Scripture from the Mettasutta of the Sutta Nipāta, tr. V. Fausböll, in *The Dhammapada and Sutta-Nipāta* (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 10, 1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3·7

Hot Water

...for dust thou art, and into dust thou shalt return.
— Genesis 3:19

Ganito ang narinig ko, on the Garces Highway.

I. The Walkout

Delano, California · September 1965

Celestino Abellana came from Bohol, from a town above the river where his father taught the fourth grade and owned four hundred coconut trees. That made the Abellanas people of some standing. In 1929, when Celestino was nineteen, his father sold sixty of the trees and bought him passage to San Francisco and a fountain pen, so that he could study at the university in California and come home an engineer.

He got as far as the asparagus. By the spring of 1930 he was on his knees in the peat of the Delta islands west of Stockton with a long knife, cutting spears at first light, and the fountain pen was in a pawnshop on Lafayette Street. He never went home. Nobody he knew went home. For thirty-six years he followed the crops up and down the state, asparagus and lettuce and apricots and tomatoes and grapes, and by the time he was fifty-five he was what all of them were, a manong, an old bachelor in a bunkhouse with a good suit in a cardboard box under his cot, because California would not let him marry a white girl and there were hardly any Filipinas to marry.

On the night of the seventh of September, 1965, he sat on a folding chair in the Filipino Community Hall in Delano with more than a thousand other men, and they voted to walk out of the vineyards in the morn-

ing. The vote was all hands. Celestino raised his with the rest, and found that his heart had gone up with it. He felt as if he had been waiting thirty-six years to put it somewhere.

The growers turned off the water in the camps. Then they put the men out. Celestino left the camp where he had slept for eleven seasons with his suitcase in one hand and the suit box under his arm, and nine of them together rented an old ranch house on the Garces Highway with a pepper tree in the yard and a kitchen big enough to cook for twenty.

He gave up the cards. He gave up the dice. He swept the hall and stood on the picket lines with a sign until his legs shook, and when the younger men from the other union, the Mexicans, called the old Filipinos *los manongs* and brought them coffee, he thanked them in Spanish and drank it. The men in the Garces house called him Tino. They said that of all of them, Tino had come over the furthest.

There was one man in the house who called him Celestino. That was Ambrosio Dacanay, an Ilocano from Laoag, sixty-three years old, who had been a houseboy in Berkeley in the twenties and had read his employers' books while he dusted them. He had a library card from the Kern County library and kept it in his shirt pocket behind a pencil. The men called him Propesor. He had not been inside a church since the year the boy Fermin Tobera was shot through the wall of a bunkhouse at Watsonville, which was 1930, and if anyone asked him about God he talked about something else.

He did not talk much about anything. But twice a day, once at first light and once after supper, Propesor walked the house and the yard and looked in on every man. He looked at who was coughing and who had not eaten. He looked at whose hands were shaking and whose shoes were by his cot and whose were not. Then he went to bed or went to work. The men were used to it. They hardly saw him do it anymore.

II. The Mustard Seed

Delano · spring and summer 1973

The first one came up on his shin in March, a red point no bigger than a mustard seed. Tino scratched it and forgot it.

By April there were a dozen of them, on both shins and on the backs of his hands, and the first one was the size of a monggo bean. In May they were the size of garbanzos. That spring and summer the union's grape contracts ran out, first down in the desert at Coachella and then here, and the growers signed with the Teamsters instead, and the strike began again, the whole thing, the pickets and the sheriff's deputies and the trucks coming out of the vineyards with their windows rolled up. The old men in the Garces house went out on the line in the mornings in their straw hats. Tino went with them, in long sleeves buttoned at the wrist.

In June the sores on his shins were the size of Thompson seedless grapes. In July they were as big as walnuts, and the biggest, on his left ankle, was as big as a Santa Rosa plum and the same dark color. Then, one after another, they opened.

After that there was no hiding them. The smell went before him into a room. His long-sleeved shirt stuck to his forearms and had to be peeled off at night, and the cotton undershirt underneath it dried stiff and brown with what came out of him, until it was like the crust at the bottom of the rice pot, the tutong, that comes away in one piece. The men in the house started calling him Tino Bulok, rotten Tino, behind his back. Then, because he did not seem to mind, they called him that to his face.

He went to the union clinic out at the Forty Acres, and the doctor there, a young man with a beard, looked at the ankle a long time. He said it was the sugar diabetes and an infection on top of it, and that the infection had gone into the bone of the foot and was eating the bone. He said Tino had to go to the county hospital in Bakersfield and let them take the foot off, and maybe the leg below the knee.

Tino said, *I came into this country on this foot.* He said it pleasantly. He did not go to Bakersfield.

That summer, out at the Forty Acres, the union was building a house for the old men. It was going to be called Agbayani Village, after Paulo Agbayani, a manong who had dropped dead of a heart attack on a picket line, and it was going to have fifty-nine rooms around a courtyard, with white walls and a red tile roof, and a kitchen that cooked Filipino food, and a garden. Volunteers had come from all over California to build it, college students from Los Angeles and Berkeley, Filipino and Japanese and Chinese kids with long hair and bandanas who called the old men *Manong* and asked them questions about 1930 and wrote the answers in notebooks. On Sundays the men from the Garces house drove out in Siso's Plymouth to watch the walls go up. Each of them had picked out his room. Tino had picked one on the east side, for the morning.

By August he could not walk out to see it anymore. The bones of his left foot had begun to go. He could feel them moving against each other when he put his weight on it, like gravel in a sack.

III. The Pepper Tree

The Garces house · August 1973

It was a hundred and six degrees in Delano on the day they moved him out.

Nobody decided it, exactly. It was decided at the kitchen table over rice and dried fish, the way everything in the house was decided, with the radio on. Siso said the smell got into the rice. Pidiong said his brother in Stockton had caught something like that from a man in a bunkhouse in 1948 and lost an eye. Andoy, who was Visayan like Tino and the oldest of them after Propesor, said nothing for a long time and then said the word they had all been not saying, which was *gaba*. It was the old word from home for the thing that comes back on you. You waste rice, you mock an old person, you are cruel to an animal, and one day it comes back on you. Nobody has to send it. It comes by itself.

He must have done something, said Andoy. *A man doesn't rot like that for nothing.*

Propesor was at work that day, weeding a Japanese family's strawberries out by McFarland, because a man has to eat during a strike too. So the others carried Tino's cot out into the yard and set it under the pepper tree by the chicken wire, where there was shade until two in the afternoon. They gave him a gallon jug of water and a fly swatter and a coffee can. They told him it was cooler outside.

It was not cooler outside. Tino thanked them anyway.

That night the radio said that a young striker from Yemen, one of the Arab boys who had walked the lines with them, was dead in Kern County after a deputy had hit him in the head. Two days later it said that a man named Juan de la Cruz, sixty years old, had been shot on a picket line near Arvin. The men in the house sat at the table with the radio and did not go to bed, and out in the yard under the pepper tree Tino lay and listened to it through the screen door, because they had left the door open so they could hear him if he called. He did not call.

On the third night the canvas of the old army cot gave way under him at one end, and he slid down onto the dirt and lay there. He did not have the strength to get up and he did not want to wake anybody. The ants found the ankle before morning.

IV. The Kaldero

The next morning

Propesor came out into the yard at first light, as he always did, and stood by the chicken wire and looked.

Tino was lying half on the broken cot and half on the ground, on his side, with his cheek in the dirt and his eyes open. His shirt had dried onto him. There were ants going in a line up the cot leg and down again.

Propesor stood there longer than he usually stood anywhere. He was thinking that the men in the house were not bad men. They were old and they were scared and they had nothing, and when you have nothing you are careful with it, even your own nose, even your own fear. He was thinking that Tino had no brother and no wife and no son, and that his father and his four hundred coconut trees were forty years in the ground

in Bohol, and that the union had its hands full and the priest did not come out this far. He was thinking that the man had nobody now but him.

He did not go to Tino. He went into the kitchen.

He took down the big aluminum kaldero they cooked the rice in for nine men, and he scrubbed it out at the sink with steel wool until it shone, and filled it at the tap, and put it on the big burner and lit the gas. Then he stood by the stove with his arms folded and waited for it, the way you stand by rice. Pidiong came in yawning in his undershirt and looked at Propesor and looked at the pot and opened his mouth and shut it again. The water ticked against the bottom. It began to tremble. When it came up to a boil Propesor turned down the flame, and walked out through the screen door into the yard, and bent down and took hold of the end of Tino's cot with both hands.

He was seventy-one years old and the cot was heavy. It did not move.

By then Pidiong was at the screen door and Siso was behind him and Andoy behind Siso, and all of them were barefoot and none of them looked at each other.

Manong, said Siso. *Leave it. Go on, go inside. We'll carry him for you.*

Four of them carried him in, one at each corner, and set him down on a blanket on the kitchen floor by the stove, and stood back against the counters.

Propesor brought the white enamel dishpan and poured the hot water into it and tempered it with cold until he could hold his hand in it. Then he knelt and began to work Tino's long-sleeved shirt off him, wetting it where it stuck, a little at a time, button by button, and when it was off he held it up without looking at anyone in particular.

Wash this, he said. *Hot water. Soap. Rinse it twice and hang it on the fence.*

Andoy took it. He put it in the sink and poured hot water from the kaldero over it and rubbed it with the yellow bar of laundry soap, and the water went brown and he poured it out and did it again. Then he carried it out and pinned it to the chicken wire in the sun. It was not yet eight o'clock in the morning and it was already ninety-four degrees.

Propesor soaked the undershirt off Tino the way you soak a label off a jar. Then he washed him.

He did it with a dish towel and the yellow soap, the way a man washes a man, not gently and not roughly. He washed his face and his ears and the back of his neck. He washed his chest, where the ribs were, and his arms, and his hands, which were swollen and split and still had the knuckles of a man who had cut asparagus for nine seasons. He washed the shins where the sores were, and what was left of the ankle, holding the foot in his palm as if it were something he was buying and wanted to see from underneath. Twice he sent Pidiong to pour out the dishpan in the yard and fill it again from the kaldero. Nobody in the kitchen said anything. The radio was off.

When he was finished he sat back on his heels. Siso went out to the fence and came back with the long-sleeved shirt, and it was dry. He held it out with a puzzled face, as if he had expected to have to explain why it was not.

Propesor put it on Tino, one arm and then the other, and buttoned it to the throat and at both wrists. Then he unbuckled Tino's work trousers and drew them off and gave them to Andoy, and Andoy washed them in the sink and took them out and pinned them on the wire by the cuffs. Propesor dried Tino's legs with a clean towel, carefully, between the toes. He did not finish. By the time he stood up to look for the second towel, the last of the water had gone off Tino's skin by itself in the heat of the kitchen, and Andoy was coming back through the screen door with the trousers over his arm, dry and stiff and warm as bread.

They dressed him. They put him in Propesor's own cot in the front room, where the shade was, on a clean sheet. Propesor wet a comb at the sink and combed back Tino's hair with brilliantine from the tin Tino kept in his suitcase, and parted it on the left, the way he had worn it in 1930.

Tino lay on his back with his hands on the sheet. He looked at the ceiling, and then at the window, and then at Propesor. His face had changed. He looked like a man who has been carrying a sack of some-

thing all day in the sun and has just put it down and has not yet straightened up.

Propesor pulled a kitchen chair to the head of the cot and sat on it.

Celestino, he said. *It won't be long now. You'll go out like a lamp. And then they'll put this in the ground, and it won't know anything. It'll lie there like one of those old vines they pull up at the end of the row and throw on the pile.*

Tino looked at him.

Then Propesor said the thing the priest says on Ash Wednesday, with his thumb in the ashes, the thing every boy in the Ilocos and every boy in Bohol had heard said over his own forehead every year of his childhood, except that he said all of it, the way it was written, from the beginning.

> *In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread till thou return to the earth, out of which thou wast taken: for dust thou art, and into dust thou shalt return.*
>
> *— Genesis 3:19*

Tino was quiet a while. Then he smiled, with his eyes more than his mouth.

You don't even believe that, Ambo.

No, said Propesor. *It's true anyway.*

Out in the yard a mockingbird was going through every song it knew in the pepper tree. Tino turned his head on the pillow toward the window to listen to it. A little before noon he let out a long breath, the kind a man lets out when he sits down after a day in the rows, and did not take another.

V. The East Room

Delano · August 1973 to spring 1974

Propesor did all of it. He went to the county office in Bakersfield for the papers. He went to the funeral home in town and argued about the price in Ilocano and English and paid it out of the coffee can where the house kept its money for the dead, because they had al-

ways buried each other and there was nobody else to do it. He went to the rectory, and the priest came, and the funeral Mass was said at the church in town, and Propesor stood at the very back by the holy water with his hat in his hands, where the men from the Garces house could see that he had come inside.

They buried Tino in the cemetery at the edge of town, in his good suit, the brown one from 1931 that was too big for him now. Volunteers came from the Forty Acres, some of the long-haired kids, and stood at the grave in their work boots with mortar still on them. One of the girls had brought her notebook and did not know what to do with it and held it against her chest.

In the spring of 1974 Agbayani Village was finished, and the union opened it with a big ceremony at the Forty Acres, and the old men moved in with their suitcases and their suit boxes, each man to his own room, with a bed that was not a cot and a window that opened. Propesor went last. Before he carried his own things in, he took a hammer and a nail and went along the east side of the courtyard to the room Tino had picked, and hung a photograph on the wall beside the door.

It was the only picture of Tino anyone could find. It had been taken on Lafayette Street in Stockton in 1931 by a man who did it for a quarter. In it Celestino Abellana is twenty-one years old, in a wide-shouldered suit, with his hair parted on the left and shining. He is holding a gamecock in his two hands against his chest, a red one with a black tail, and he is looking down at it instead of at the camera.

Nobody ever moved into that room. The union put an old man from Lamont in it in the fall, and he said there were too many birds in the morning, and moved to the west side.

VI. Talunan

Agbayani Village · 1974

The men from the Garces house still ate together at one end of the long table in the new dining hall, and still argued, and still said the things they had said in the old kitchen, only now there were

twenty other men to hear them. One night in the summer, after the plates had gone back, Andoy said it.

Propesor. Where is he now?

Who?

Tino. Heaven? Purgatory? Where?

Propesor turned his coffee cup a quarter turn on the table.

Nowhere, he said. *He finished.*

Andoy did not like that answer. None of them did. Siso said that was no answer. Pidiong said what kind of a thing was that to say about a man. Andoy put his two hands flat on the table.

Then tell me this. He was the best of us. On the line he was the best of us. Why does a man like that rot like a dead dog under a tree? Why do his bones go? And then, at the end, why does he go so easy? I have seen men die. Nobody dies like that. He went like a man getting on a bus.

Propesor did not say anything for a long time, and they thought he was not going to. Then he said: *You want gaba, Andoy. I'll give you gaba. But you have to take the whole thing.*

• • •

In the thirties, he said, he and Tino had shared a room in Stockton over a barbershop on Lafayette Street, two cots and one window, when they were not out in the camps. In those years Celestino Abellana was the best cocker in the Delta. He had the hands for it. He raised his birds under the bunkhouse on Roberts Island in wire pens he built himself, and on Saturday nights he carried them in sacks to the pits out on the islands, where the men stood around a square of boards under gasoline lanterns and the money changed hands faster than anyone could count it. The pits were against the law. Everybody went.

His best birds he sold to the big men, the labor contractors who drove Packards and the gamblers who came out from town in white shoes. The birds he kept and fought himself, and when they won, he won. When they lost, he had a bird with the blade still in it.

A dead bird spoils by morning in the Delta in July. A live one keeps. So Celestino did not kill the losers. He took each one in his good hands be-

hind the pit, and snapped its legs, and snapped its wings at the first joint, so that it could not beat itself to pieces or get out of the crate, and he laid it in the crate on top of the others. Propesor said you could hear the crates all night from the road. In the morning Celestino sold them to the camp cooks, for talunan, which is what you make from a losing bird, a sour stew, with vinegar and ginger, because the meat is tough. The ones nobody bought he cooked for himself.

That's your gaba, said Propesor. *If you need some.*

Nobody at the end of the table said anything. Across the dining hall the cook was stacking pans.

Now the other part, Propesor said.

In the winter of 1933 there was no work anywhere. Men were sleeping in the asparagus sheds. One day in January Celestino had a pot of adobo on the hot plate in the room on Lafayette Street, made from his own birds, the good ones, the thighs, with garlic and black pepper, cooked down until it shone. There was enough for a week if he was careful. He was setting the table, which was a suitcase, when somebody knocked.

It was an old man. Older than any of them were then. A manong from one of the first boats, maybe, from before the war, walking from the asparagus camps to wherever he was walking to, in a coat with no buttons and a cardboard suitcase tied with twine. He did not ask for anything. He stood in the hall with his hat in his hand and looked past them at the pot.

Propesor said he had watched Celestino look at the old man, and look at the pot, and look at the old man again. And then Celestino took the one good plate they had and filled it, all the thighs, all the way to the edge, and put rice beside it, and gave it to him with both hands. And then he did a thing Propesor had never seen him do for anybody, not for the contractors, not for the priest. He took the old man's free hand and pressed the back of it against his own forehead, the way you do for your grandfather.

Manong, he said. *Wherever it is you're going, pray that I get there too.*

And the old man looked at him a while, with the plate in one hand, and said, *Sige. Okay.*

He ate it in the hall, standing up. Then he put on his hat and went down the stairs, and they never saw him again.

• • •

That's all of it, said Propesor. *The legs and the wings. And the plate. You want to know why he rotted, that's why. You want to know why he went easy, that's why. It's the same man. You don't get to keep one half.*

He got up and took his cup to the window where the dishes went. The men sat for a while, and then one at a time they went to their rooms.

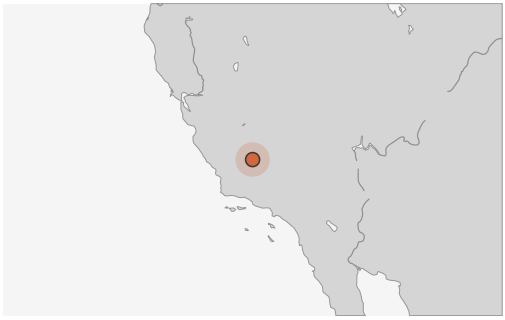
Propesor was the last one in the dining hall. The cook had left a pot of chicken on the back of the stove for the morning. He took a bowl down from the shelf and filled it, the best pieces on top, all the way to the edge, and spooned rice beside them, and carried it out through the kitchen door and set it on the step, in the warm dark, facing east. Then he went inside and turned out the light and did not look to see who came.

Background

The verse

> *Before long, alas! this body will lie on the earth, despised, without understanding, like a useless log.*
>
> Dhammapada 41, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young man of good family from Sāvatthī becomes a monk named Tissa. Sores break out over his body, growing from the size of mustard seeds to the size of large fruit, until they burst; his robes stiffen with blood and his bones begin to break apart, and his fellow monks, unable to bear it, put him out on the ground. The Buddha, who surveys the world at dawn and at dusk, sees him. He goes to the fire-hall, washes a pot and heats water, and takes hold of the end of Tissa's bed, and the monks hurry to carry it in for him. The Buddha has Tissa's robes washed and dried in the sun while he bathes him with his own hands, dresses him, and speaks this verse at his pillow. Tissa reaches awakening and dies. When the monks ask why so good a monk suffered so, the Buddha tells them that in a past life Tissa was a fowler who broke the legs and wings of his captive birds so they could not escape, and who once filled the bowl of a saint at his door with his best food and asked to reach what the saint had reached. Read the full commentary story.



Delano, California

Delano, 1973

Young Filipino men came to California in large numbers in the 1920s and early 1930s, until the Tydings–McDuffie Act of 1934 all but closed the door, and they did much of the state's migrant field work. Laws against interracial marriage, and how few Filipina women had come, left most of them single for life; they are remembered as the manong generation, from the Ilocano word for elder brother. Stockton's Little Manila was their winter home, and they met violence across the state, most notoriously in the Watsonville riots of January 1930, when Fermin Tobera was shot dead in a bunkhouse. On September 7, 1965, Filipino members of the Agricultural Workers Organizing Committee met at the Filipino Community Hall in Delano and voted to strike the table-grape growers the next morning, the beginning of the five-year Delano grape strike. Many of the strikers were past fifty. Growers cut off water to the labor camps and put the men out.

When the union's grape contracts expired in 1973 and growers signed with the Teamsters, the strike resumed, and in mid-August two strikers were killed in Kern County: Nagi Daifallah, a young Yemeni immigrant struck by a sheriff's deputy, and Juan de la Cruz, shot on a picket line near Arvin (Welga Digital Archive). That same season some thousand volunteers were building Agbayani Village, a fifty-nine-room retirement home for the old Filipino strikers at the union's Forty Acres outside Delano, named for Paulo Agbayani, who died of a heart attack on a picket line. It opened in 1974. Andoy's word *gabà* is the Visayan idea of a comeuppance that falls on wrongdoers, cruelty to animals among them, with no god needed to send it; *talunan*, "loser," is the sour stew made from the tough meat of a rooster that lost its fight.

After the story of the Elder Pūtigatta Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 41). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3.8

Blaze Orange

The body they may kill:
God's truth abideth still.
— "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God," tr. F. H. Hedge

Kuv hnov hais li no, on the east side of Wausau.

I. The Steer

Marathon County, Wisconsin · spring 1998

Walt Brandt milked ninety Holsteins in a tie-stall barn on County Road N, west of Marathon City, in the same barn where his father had milked forty, and he was the one farmer in the township the Hmong families called when somebody died.

It started by accident. A young man named Tou Xiong drove out one April morning with a cousin and a borrowed stock trailer, looking for a steer. The farms nearer town had told him no, or named a price meant to send him home. Walt had a Holstein steer he had kept back for the freezer. He sold it for what it would have brought at the sale barn, and helped them load it, and asked what it was for.

My uncle's wife, said Tou. *For the funeral.*

The uncle had come along. He stood by the trailer in a gray nylon windbreaker with his hands folded behind his back, a small old man with a face as brown and creased as a harness, and before they loaded the steer he walked around it twice, slowly. He ran his palm down its back. He looked at its feet and its eyes and the inside of its lip. It was how Walt's father used to go over a cow at an auction, and Walt had never seen anybody from town look at an animal like that.

He kept cattle, Tou said. *In Laos, before. Cows, buffalo, horses. He was a teacher in the school too, but everybody had cattle.*

The old man's name was Neng Chue Xiong. He said almost nothing that day, in either language. But when the steer was in the trailer he came across the yard and took Walt's hand in both of his and held it, and looked at him the way he had looked at the steer, all the way down, without hurry. Walt was forty-nine that spring. Nobody had looked at him like that in a long time, and he did not know what to do with his face.

After that it was understood. When a family in Wausau needed an animal for a funeral, somebody called the Brandt farm. Walt sold them dry cows and old cows and steers at sale-barn price, and let them take as long as they wanted choosing, and learned not to ask more than they told him. He learned that a funeral could go on three days and nights at the funeral home, that there was a long bamboo reed pipe played at it, and that whenever a family wanted something done right, they sent for the old man.

And every time Walt went into town, to the implement dealer or the bank or the vet, he drove the long way around, over the river to the east side, where the Xiongs lived in a narrow frame house with a garden that took up the whole back yard, and he left something on the porch. A gallon of milk out of the bulk tank, still cold from the stainless. A pound of butter. Two pounds of cheese curds from the cheese plant down the road, so fresh they squeaked against your teeth. A pint of cream with a paper towel rubber-banded over the top.

He would knock, and Neng Chue Xiong would come to the door and thank him with both hands, and Walt would say what he always said.

You ought to come out and see the place. Stay a few days. My folks' old house is sitting empty.

Not yet, the old man said. *Thank you. Not yet.*

Carol said to leave the poor man alone. Their son Danny, who was in high school then, said the old guy probably thought his dad was nuts. Walt kept on doing it. Seven years, the milk and the butter and the curds,

and the old man kept on saying not yet, and neither of them seemed to mind.

II. Signs

November 2004 – November 2005

THEN THE THING HAPPENED UP NORTH IN SAWYER COUNTY.

On the second morning of the deer season in 2004, on private land near Birchwood, a party of hunters found a Hmong hunter from St. Paul sitting in one of their stands and told him to get off the property. Nobody afterward agreed about everything that was said, or who raised a rifle first. When it was over, six of the hunters were dead and two were wounded, and the man from St. Paul was arrested a few hours later, when he came back out of the woods to his camp.

Walt heard it on the radio in the milkhouse. By the end of the week there was nobody in Marathon County, white or Hmong, who was not talking about it, and nobody who was talking about anything else.

That winter you heard things at the co-op you had not heard said out loud before. Somebody's brother-in-law knew a fellow up north who had found the Hmong camp and done his business in their cooking pots. Somebody had a bumper sticker. A man Walt had sat next to in church for twenty years said, standing at the feed counter, that they ought to send every one of them back where they came from, and then looked at Walt as if waiting for him to say something, and Walt paid for his mineral and went out to the truck and did not say anything, and drove home with his face hot.

In the spring Tou called and asked, carefully, whether he and his brother Kou might hunt Walt's back forty in November. Nobody else would let them on. Walt said yes. He walked the line with them in May when the ground was soft, showed them the corner posts and where his land quit and the Hessel place began, the safe directions to shoot, the road, the house, the barn. Then he sat at the kitchen table and wrote out the permission on a pad from the feed mill and signed it and dated it, and Carol witnessed it, so nobody could ever say.

That was the year Danny was in Iraq.

He had joined the Army out of high school, against everybody's advice, and now he drove a fuel truck in convoys up and down the roads north of Baghdad, roads where men buried artillery shells in the gravel shoulder and set them off with the button of a garage-door opener. Walt knew this because he had made himself learn it. He watched the news in the kitchen at noon with the sound turned low and the paper open on the table to the list of the dead, and he lay awake at night doing arithmetic. He hated the men by the roadsides. He hated them the way he had never hated anything, with his jaw, in the dark, three and four in the morning, faceless men he could see perfectly. It sat in his chest all day like a stone in a cow's gut.

Danny's blaze-orange coat hung on its hook in the mudroom, where he had left it after the last season they hunted together. Walt had told Carol he would not hunt this year without him. He walked past the coat four times a day.

In September the trial was held up in Hayward and the man from St. Paul was convicted of all six killings. In November, the week the judge gave him life, the radio stations ran announcements from the DNR about trespass and safety in English and Hmong, one after the other, and up near Birchwood the township put up No Trespassing signs printed in three languages.

The day after the sentencing, Walt drove the long way into town and left curds on the porch on the east side and knocked. He said what he always said.

Neng Chue Xiong looked at him a long time in the doorway.

Yes, he said. *Saturday. I will come.*

III. The Bur Oak

The Brandt farm · the week before the opener

He did not come up to the house. Walt found him on Saturday morning when the milk truck pulled out, sitting under the big bur oak at the end of the lane, on a folding canvas chair he must have

BROUGHT WITH HIM, WITH A PLASTIC GROCERY BAG AT HIS feet and his hands folded on his knees. Tou had dropped him there at daybreak on his way to the Saturday shift at the paper mill. The oak still had its leaves, brown and stiff, the way bur oaks hold them into winter, and they rattled over his head in the wind.

Mr. Xiong. Why didn't you come up?

I am up, said the old man, and smiled for the first time Walt had ever seen.

Carol aired out the old house and made up the bed with the good quilt. And for seven days Walt Brandt fed him.

Every morning after milking he carried down a gallon of milk drawn warm from the tank before the cooler took it, a dish of cream, butter Carol had worked in the kitchen with the paddle that had been her mother's, curds, cottage cheese, a wedge of brick cheese from the plant down the road. In the evenings Tou and Kou came out after work to look over the back forty before the opener, and the boy Pheng, Tou's son, seventeen, who drove his great-uncle wherever he needed to go, and they all ate together in his parents' old kitchen, Hmong food out of plastic tubs from the east side and Walt's milk and butter, and Walt noticed that no one ever went away hungry from that table and nothing was ever left over.

The old man came up to the barn at milking. He did not ask to; he simply came and stood in the alley in his windbreaker with his hands behind his back and watched. The cows, which did not like strangers, did not seem to notice him. On Wednesday night a heifer had trouble calving, and while Walt was going for the chains the old man went into the pen and put one hand flat on her flank and talked to her low in Hmong, and by the time Walt got back the calf was out on the straw and the heifer was licking it and the old man was wiping his hands on a feed sack.

They talked, slowly, in the evenings, after the nephews went home. Walt did most of it. The old man asked short questions and waited for long answers. He asked about Walt's father and the forty cows. He asked about the milk price, which was better than it had been, and the bank. He asked about Danny.

Some of what the old man said about himself, Walt pieced together later. That he had taught children to read in a village in the mountains of Laos until the war came up the valley. That he had carried a rifle for the Americans after that, for twelve years, and that most of the boys he had taught to read had carried rifles too, and that most of them were dead. That in the spring of 1975 he had walked to the Mekong with his family and crossed it at night, and had lived in a camp in Thailand called Ban Vinai for seven years, and had come to Wausau in the winter of 1982 to a church basement full of donated coats, and had worked eleven summers on his knees under the black shade cloth in the ginseng gardens west of town.

On Thursday Walt asked him why he had never come before.

The old man thought about it. *At first you brought milk so I would come,* he said. *That is a good reason. Then after some years you brought milk because you bring milk. That is a better reason. Now I came.*

Thursday night Walt told him about the men by the roadsides, and the arithmetic at three in the morning, and the man at the feed counter, and the stone. He had not told Carol all of it. He had not told the pastor any of it. The old man listened with his eyes on the floor. When it was done he said nothing at all for a long time, and then he said only, *Yes. I know that one.* And he went to bed.

Walt went out and did the late check on the heifer, and found himself singing to the cows under his breath the way his father used to, the old hymn from church, the one his father had liked best, *A mighty fortress is our God, a bulwark never failing,* all four verses, the words coming back to him one after another out of the dark of the barn like cows coming in to their stalls.

On Friday evening, the seventh day, he was in the milkhouse washing up when the compressor on the bulk tank shut off. It had been running so long that he had stopped hearing it. When it quit, the whole room rang with the quiet, and Walt stood there with the hose in his hand and understood that the stone was gone. He could not have said where it went. Danny was still in Iraq. The roads were still the roads. The men by them were still men, some of them no older than Danny, with mothers

who read lists. He stood in the clean wet milkhouse and breathed, and it went all the way down.

He went out to tell the old man and found him sitting in the folding chair under the bur oak in the dark, with his collar up, looking at the barn lights.

Something happened, Walt said.

Yes, said Neng Chue Xiong. *Good. Tomorrow I go home.*

IV. Stop Here

Saturday · the opener

They walked down the lane together a little after six in the morning, in the gray before sunrise, with the frost white on the hay stubble and the oak rattling at the bottom of the hill. Walt had already milked. He carried the old man's grocery bag and the folded canvas chair. Down at the road Pheng's little Honda sat with its parking lights on and its exhaust going up straight in the cold. Tou and Kou had been in the back forty since five, sitting against two trees on the far fence line in their orange coats, waiting for light.

All over the county trucks were parked on the shoulders. All over the state, more than half a million people sat in the woods with rifles across their knees, watching the dark go gray. In a few minutes it would be legal to shoot.

Halfway down the lane, the old man stopped and turned and took his bag and his chair.

Stop here, he said. *Go back to your cows.*

Walt had meant to walk him to the car. He had meant, honestly, to stand by the car window and say something, though he did not know what. But he stopped. He did what he was told, the way he had done everything for a week. The old man took Walt's hand in both of his and held it, and then went on down the lane with the bag and the chair, small and gray, and Walt turned around and started back.

He cut across the hayfield toward the lights of the barn, the shortest way, the way he had walked ten thousand times. He was wearing his

brown canvas chore coat and his seed cap. Danny's orange coat was hanging on its hook in the mudroom.

The first shots of the season began, the way they always did, all at once, a flat popping from every direction like the first corn in a pan, from the county forest and the Hessel place and the river bottom and the farms across the road.

Pheng, standing by the open door of the Honda, saw Walt go down in the stubble. He said afterward that he did not hear one shot louder than the others. Walt simply knelt, as if to look at something on the ground, and then lay down on his side.

The old man dropped the bag and the chair and went back up the hill faster than Pheng had ever seen him move. By the time Pheng got there, with the cell phone at his ear, Neng Chue Xiong was kneeling in the frost with Walt's head on his knee, and his hand flat on Walt's chest the way he had laid it on the heifer, and he was talking to him low in Hmong, and Walt was looking up past him at the brown leaves of the oak, and then he was not looking at anything.

Across the field, by the barn, the cows were bawling to be let out.

V. The Wardens

Saturday to Sunday night

Two deputies came, and the ambulance, which was no use, and before nine o'clock three wardens from the DNR, who walked the field in a line with their heads down. They found where Walt had fallen, and they stood there a long time looking west, toward the fence line and the woods, and then north, and then west again.

They took Tou's rifle and Kou's rifle, gently, with paper tags on the trigger guards, and sat the brothers at Carol's kitchen table in their orange coats for four hours, one at a time, with a deputy in the doorway. They asked Pheng to tell it again and again. They asked the old man, through Pheng, where he had been standing, and he showed them.

By noon it was all over the county. By the time the bars in Marathon City filled up on Saturday night there was nobody in them who did not

know that Walt Brandt had been shot dead on his own land on opening morning, and that Walt Brandt had let Hmong hunt his back forty, and that two Hmong had been in his back forty with rifles when it happened. Nobody needed to say the rest. A rock came through the front window of a Hmong grocery on the east side on Sunday morning. On Sunday afternoon somebody at the gas station on Highway 29 told Carol's sister how sorry he was, and said they would hang for it this time, by God, and she said thank you.

On Sunday night the Xiong family sat on the living room floor of the house on the east side, twenty of them, more, with the curtains drawn and the porch light off. Tou had been crying, and was angry that he had been crying, and he said it to his uncle in Hmong in front of everyone.

If you had not gone out there, he would be alive. He gave us his land. He gave you his milk for seven years. And you went out and sat under his tree, and he walked you down his road, and now he is dead, and they will say it was us. They are already saying it. If you had stayed home, none of this.

The room was quiet. The old man sat on a kitchen chair with his hands folded on his knees.

If I stayed home, he said, *if he stayed home, if he went north, if he went south, if he went east to the river or west to the woods, it was going to find him that morning. I did not bring it. You did not bring it. Nobody here can stop the thing that comes to a man.*

He looked around the room at all of them, the brothers in their hunting clothes, the women, the children on the stairs.

Listen. A man with a gun can do that to a man. An enemy can do that to his enemy. One who hates, to the one he hates. You know this. All of us know this. But a mind that is pointed the wrong way will do worse to the man who carries it. Worse than any gun. Now everybody out there is pointing his mind. Do not point yours back.

Some of them, years later, said that was the night they stopped being afraid in the place where they had been afraid since Birchwood. They could not explain it better than that. Tou went out on the porch and turned the light back on.

VI. The Hymn

Marathon City · the Wednesday before Thanksgiving

DANNY BRANDT GOT HOME TUESDAY NIGHT, THIRTY HOURS out of Baghdad by way of Kuwait, on emergency leave, in a uniform that still had the dust of the convoy route in its seams. He hugged his mother in the doorway for a long time. He did not cry. He walked out to the hayfield in the dark by himself and stood on the place, and came back in, and took his father's deer rifle out of the gun cabinet in the den and cleaned it at the kitchen table, all of it, every part, and put it back together and did not put it away.

The funeral was at the Methodist church on Wednesday morning. The church was full and the basement was full and people stood along the walls. Carol had chosen the hymns. The last one was Walt's father's, and Walt's.

The old man came, with Tou and Pheng, in white shirts and dark jackets, and sat in the last pew on the left. Danny saw heads turn. He saw a woman he had known all his life get up from that pew with her husband and move to the other side. He saw the man from the feed counter look at the three of them and look away. The old man sat with his hands folded on his knees and looked at the casket.

They stood for the last hymn. The organ was loud. Danny did not sing. He held the hymnal open and read the words in front of him as if they were orders.

> *Let goods and kindred go,*
> *This mortal life also;*
> *The body they may kill:*
> *God's truth abideth still,*
> *His kingdom is forever.*
>
> *— "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God," Martin Luther, tr. F. H. Hedge (1853), st. 4*

At the lunch in the basement, over ham sandwiches and bars and the big percolator, his uncle Gary put a hand on his shoulder and said low that

the state crime lab had the bullet, and the rifles, and it was a matter of days, and everybody knew whose rifles were in that field. *You let the law do it, Dan.* Danny nodded.

On Thursday his mother cooked Thanksgiving dinner for eleven people because she did not know what else to do, and Danny ate, and helped with the dishes, and after dark he put on his own orange coat for the warmth of it and put his father's rifle in the truck and drove into town.

VII. The Ancient Foe

The east side · Thanksgiving night

He parked across the street from the narrow frame house with the engine running for the heat and the rifle across his knees. He did not know what he had come to do. He had driven a fuel truck past a hundred houses like this one on the other side of the world with a rifle across his knees, and he had always known what he had come to do, and now he did not, and that frightened him more than anything had frightened him over there.

After twenty minutes the porch light came on and the old man came down the steps in a parka and house slippers and crossed the street, and opened the passenger door of the truck, and got in, and shut the door. He looked at the rifle. Then he looked out the windshield.

They sat a while.

Your father told me you drive the fuel, Neng Chue Xiong said. *On the roads with the bombs.*

He told you that.

Every night. Seven nights. You were the only thing he talked about that he was afraid of. The old man was quiet. *On Thursday night he sang a song to the cows. The one they sang in your church.*

Danny's hands tightened on the rifle.

There is a part of the song, the old man said. *Your father sang it for me twice, so I could learn it.* And he said it, slowly, in his careful English, looking out the windshield at his own lit porch.

For still our ancient foe
Doth seek to work us woe;
His craft and power are great;
And armed with cruel hate,
On earth is not his equal.

— "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God," tr. F. H. Hedge (1853), st. 1

Your father said this one is the devil. I think so. But I do not think he is out there. The old man put two fingers on his own chest, on the parka. *Thirty years he lived in here. In me. I hated the ones who came up the valley. I hated them in the camp, in the church basement, on my knees in the ginseng. Every night. It did nothing to them. Nothing. They never knew. It ate me. The man in the woods killed your father's body. Your song says it. The body they may kill. But this one,* and he touched his chest again, *can do worse than that, to you. He is armed with cruel hate. On earth is not his equal. He is sitting in this truck.*

Danny did not say anything for a long time. Then he said, *Who did it?*

I don't know.

Was it your nephews?

No.

How do you know?

The old man thought about it honestly. *I know them,* he said. *But I did not see. It is not the question.* He opened the door and the cold came in. *Go home to your mother. Your cows are waiting.*

Danny drove home with the rifle on the floor of the truck. In the mudroom he unloaded it and put the shells in his coat pocket and stood the rifle in the corner and hung up the orange coat on its hook, beside his father's brown one.

• • •

On Friday morning the warden called. A boy of fifteen, Kyle Hessel, from the next farm west, had come into the sheriff's office the night before with his grandfather. At first light on opening morning he had shot at a buck running along the fence line between the two farms, and missed it, he thought, and never saw where the bullet went. He had heard on Sat-

urday night what happened to Mr. Brandt. He had not eaten in five days. The crime lab matched the bullet to his rifle by noon. Tou and Kou got theirs back that afternoon, with the paper tags still on.

Nobody asked the old man what Walt Brandt had done, in this life or some other one, to come to such an end in his own hayfield. So he never said.

Danny drove over to the Hessel place on Saturday. The boy was sitting on the back steps in his barn coat with his arms around his knees, and when he saw who it was he stood up as if to be hit. Danny sat down on the step below him. They looked at the field for a while, where the fence line ran down to the woods. Then Danny told him the things his father had told him when he was twelve: that you keep the safety on until you see the whole animal. That you know what is behind it. That a bullet does not stop where you stop looking.

The boy cried, finally. Danny sat with him until he was done.

VIII. Opening Day

The Brandt farm · November 2006

Danny's enlistment ran out in the summer, and he came home to the barn. That fall a family on the east side needed a cow for a grandmother's funeral, and they called the Brandt farm, and Danny walked them through the dry cows with a flashlight and let them take as long as they wanted.

On the Saturday before Thanksgiving, after milking, he went out the mudroom door a little before six in his orange coat. Tou and Kou and Pheng were waiting by the machine shed in theirs, stamping in the cold, and they went out together down the lane in the gray toward the back forty.

The old man was sitting at the bottom of the hill under the bur oak in his folding chair, with a thermos of Carol's coffee and a blanket on his knees and an orange stocking cap that Danny had bought him at the farm store pulled down over his ears. The leaves rattled over his head. He watched them go.

Four orange shapes, crossing the frost toward the woods, bright as a fire in the stubble, so that anybody sitting out there with a rifle across his knees could see them coming a long way off.

Background

The verse

> *Whatever a hater may do to a hater, or an enemy to an enemy, a wrongly-directed mind will do us greater mischief.*
>
> Dhammapada 42, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Nanda is a wealthy herdsman who tends the cattle of the great lay patron Anāthapiṇḍika. For a long time he keeps inviting the Buddha to his home, and the Buddha waits until Nanda is ready. At last the Buddha sits down under a tree near Nanda's place, and Nanda feeds the monks with the products of the cow for seven days. On the seventh day he hears a teaching and enters the stream. He carries the Buddha's bowl a long way down the road, until the Buddha tells him to stop and turn back. On the way home a hunter's arrow kills him. The monks say that if the Buddha had never come, Nanda would still be alive. The Buddha answers that wherever Nanda had gone, he could not have escaped that death, and speaks the verse about the wrongly directed mind. No one asks what Nanda had done in a past life, so the Buddha says nothing about it. Read the full commentary story, or about Anāthapiṇḍika, whose herds Nanda kept.

Marathon County, Wisconsin

Central Wisconsin, 2005

Hmong families began arriving in Wausau as refugees in the late 1970s, most of them families of men who had fought for the CIA against the Pathet Lao and North

Vietnamese in the Laotian Civil War. After 1975 tens of thousands crossed the Mekong into Thailand. Many spent years in camps such as Ban Vinai before churches and agencies resettled them in towns like Wausau, where by 2002 Hmong residents made up about an eighth of the city. Many of the first generation worked in Marathon County's ginseng gardens, under black shade cloth. More on the Hmong in Wisconsin.

On November 21, 2004, the second day of the gun deer season, a confrontation over a tree stand on private land near Birchwood left six white hunters dead and two wounded. The shooter, Chai Soua Vang, a Hmong hunter from St. Paul, was convicted in September 2005 and sentenced that November to life without parole; the hunters and Vang gave sharply different accounts of who fired first. The killings left deep tension between white and Hmong hunters. When the 2005 season opened, Hmong hunters reported harassment, the DNR aired safety and trespass announcements in Hmong, Spanish and English, and the township near the shooting posted signs in all three languages. Wisconsin's nine-day gun deer season opens on the Saturday before Thanksgiving.

After the story of Nanda the Herdsman from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 42). The original. Scripture from Martin Luther's "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God," translated by Frederic Henry Hedge (1853). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

3.9

The Midwife's Driver

> *Return whence thou camest to the house of the heart, and then close the doors behind thee.*
> *— Comenius, The Labyrinth of the World, ch. XXXVII*

Tak jsem to slyšela, on the Big Blue.

I. The Ford

The Des Plaines River, west of Chicago · Sunday, July 22, 1877

Václav Soukup was the son of the richest Bohemian on the West Side, and he had a way of looking at things that his mother said he got from his father and his father said he got from the lumber business. He looked at a thing and priced it. A horse, a hat, a lot on Eighteenth Street, a stand of white pine in Michigan he had only seen on paper. His father had come over with a carpenter's box and nothing else and now owned four acres of piled lumber on the South Branch and a brick house with a cupola, and Václav had grown up there learning that everything had a number on it somewhere, even if it was written very small.

He was twenty-six. He had a wife, Anna, who was pretty and quiet and the daughter of a man who owned a building and loan, and two little boys, Jeník and Vojta, four and two. He loved them the way he loved the house, without thinking about it, as things that were his.

That Sunday was the hottest of the summer. There had been talk all week of the railroad men striking back East, in Baltimore and Pittsburgh, of roundhouses burning. Václav did not want to hear about it. He and his friend Tomáš Pech, who had been his friend since they were boys throwing rocks at the Irish on DeKoven Street, hired a buggy before dawn and

drove out the Southwest Plank Road to the Des Plaines, to swim where the water was still clean with a basket of rye bread and sausage and beer.

The sun came up as they reached the ford below Lyons. There was a farmhouse on the far bank with smoke coming from the chimney, and on the near bank, at the edge of the willows, a woman was standing in the shallows with her sleeves rolled to the shoulder, washing her arms.

She was a big woman, past forty, broad in the back and the hip. She had been up all night at the farmhouse bringing somebody's child into the world, which Václav did not know yet, and she had come down to the river to wash before she walked back to the city. She stepped out of the water and unpinned her hair and shook it and pinned it up again, and then she took a grey shawl from a willow branch and put it around her shoulders and tied it. That was all she did. But the sun was coming flat across the river, and her hair was the color of wheat straw, and her arms were burned brown from the elbow down and white above, and for the space of a breath, with the light behind her, she was gold. All of her. Like the leaf they put on church domes in Prague.

Václav looked at her the way he looked at things. He thought, as clearly as if he had said it aloud: *If that were my wife. Or if Anna looked like that.*

The woman turned her head and looked at him across the water. It was not an angry look. It was the look of someone who has felt a hand on her and is deciding what it is.

Then it happened.

He would try to tell it, years later, to exactly one man, and he would not be able to tell it well. It was not like being struck. It was like the moment in a fever when the body you are in is suddenly very far away and very close at once, and you hear your own heart from outside. His shirt was loose at the neck and then tight across the chest. His hands on the reins were somebody else's hands, smaller, the knuckles finer, and his wedding ring slid down to the second joint and hung there. The beard he had shaved that morning was gone from under his palm. He said Tomáš's name and heard a voice say it that was not his voice.

Tomáš was down off the buggy, tying the horse to a sapling, with his back turned.

Václav got down on the other side and walked into the willows, and then he ran.

When Tomáš turned around there was the buggy and the horse and the basket and the beer. He called. He walked up and down the bank calling until the farmer came across the ford in his shirtsleeves to see who was shouting on a Sunday. The woman in the grey shawl had already gone up the road toward the city. Nobody had seen anybody go into the river. They dragged the shallows with a hay rake and found nothing. Tomáš drove back alone at noon, rehearsing what he would say at the house with the cupola, and none of it was any good.

II. The Viaduct

Chicago · the last week of July

The strike reached Chicago the next morning. The switchmen walked out of the yards, and then the men in the planing mills walked out, and then the lumber shovers along the South Branch, most of them Bohemians, put down their pikes and went into the street, because they were paid little enough when they were paid at all, and a man had to stand up sometime. By Wednesday there were crowds of ten thousand on Halsted Street. The police fired into them at the viaduct over the tracks, and the cavalry came up with sabers, and at the end of the day there were boys lying dead in the street who had only come out to look. People said that some of the dead were taken away in wagons that night and buried in a pit south of the city so nobody could count them. Nobody could say if it was true. In that week nobody could say what was true about anything.

Václav's father went to the morgue three times. His mother went to every police station on the West Side with his photograph in her purse, and the sergeants looked at it and shook their heads. A lumber shover swore he had seen young Soukup at the viaduct on Wednesday, throwing

stones, and seen him fall. It made a kind of sense. Tomáš said nothing against it. It was easier than the river.

Anna wore black from the Friday.

The one they were looking for was sleeping in the lumberyard of a man her father did business with, in a cave between two piles of hemlock boards, where nobody came because the yard was shut by the strike. On the first night she had traded Václav's gold watch to a secondhand woman on Halsted Street for a calico dress and a pair of shoes and a shawl and two dollars, and the woman had looked at her man's trousers and cropped hair and asked nothing, because that week everybody on Halsted Street was somebody they had not been the week before.

She walked the city in the calico dress. She found out what it was to walk past a saloon. She found out what it was to have a man fall into step beside her on Canal Street and say things to her quietly, pleasantly, as if he were remarking on the weather, and to be unable to make him stop, and to have no one to tell. She went to Eighteenth Street and stood across from the house with the cupola and watched her own wife come out on the steps in black with Vojta on her hip and Jeník holding her skirt. She watched her father put on his hat on the steps and take it off again and stand there turning it in his hands, and go back in. She did not cross the street. What would she have said? She did not have a voice they would know.

They held his funeral on the first Sunday in August, with no priest, because the Soukups were freethinkers, and with no body, because there was none. There was talk of a stone at the new cemetery the Bohemian societies were buying that summer out in Jefferson, where nobody would need a priest's leave to be put in the ground. A man from the lodge made a speech about the dignity of labor and the martyrs of the Halsted Street viaduct, which would have made Václav laugh, and afterward there was the *kar* at the house with the cupola, roast pork and dumplings and beer and koláče with poppy seed, for two hundred people. She stood in the street outside the hall in her calico and heard the speech through the open windows. Then she went back into the city and kept walking, because she could not think what else to do.

On the Tuesday, when the trains were running again, she found herself on Canal Street at the Burlington depot, standing behind a party of emigrants who had come through from Baltimore and been stuck in the city all through the strike. There were thirty of them, from around Tábor, with feather beds tied up in sheets. They were going to Nebraska. She stood near them because she understood their talk, and because nobody fell into step beside a woman who was standing with a family.

An old man in a sheepskin waistcoat, Matěj Kolář, who seemed to be in charge of them, watched her a while. *She keeps standing with us,* he said to his wife, *but whose girl is she?*

She said, *Uncle, I'm going where you're going.*

When the emigrant car was called she followed them along the platform. The conductor wanted a ticket. She had sixty cents left of the two dollars. She took off Václav's signet ring, gold, with a V and an S cut into it back to back, which she had worn on a string around her neck since the river, and put it in the old man's hand.

Matěj Kolář looked at the ring and looked at her and closed his fist on it. That night she rode west on a wooden bench in the emigrant car with a sleeping child across her knees that was not hers, through Aurora and across the Mississippi in the dark, toward a country she had only seen on paper.

III. The Blue

Wilber, Saline County, Nebraska · 1877–1883

Somewhere in Iowa Matěj Kolář and his brother-in-law had a long conversation at the end of the car. She heard her name in it, or the name she had given them, which was Marie, because half the women in Bohemia were called Marie and nobody would ever ask which one. She heard *Kratochvíl.* She heard *no wife.*

Josef Kratochvíl was thirty-four years old and owned the grain elevator at Wilber and a store under it on the main street and three quarter-sections of bottomland along the Big Blue, and he had no wife because the frontier did not have enough women in it to go around. Matěj Kolář had

sold him oxen the spring before. When the emigrants got down at the Wilber platform with their feather beds, the old man walked straight up the street to the store and said to Josef, *Pane Kratochvíl, we have brought you a jewel,* and Josef came down and looked at her, at her height and her hands and her teeth, and she knew exactly what he was doing, because she had done it all her life. She had looked at Anna that way across the dance floor at the Sokol hall. She had looked at a stand of pine.

He was not unkind. That was the thing she would always have to say for him, when she told it. He asked her, the next day, standing in the store with his hat in his hand, if she would have him. She had sixty cents and no name and nowhere on the earth to go. She said yes. They were married by a justice of the peace in the room above the store, because Josef was a freethinker and did not want a priest, and the Kolářs danced at the wedding, and Matěj Kolář got a good price on his seed wheat that fall and every fall afterward.

She learned the life. She learned to cook for threshers and wash on a board and keep the store books, because Josef could not add. She learned what it was to be talked about at the counter by men who did not lower their voices because she was only the wife. She learned how the farmers' wives were, the ones who came in on Saturdays with butter and eggs to trade, women who had broken sod with a team and buried children in the corner of a claim and walked behind a plow pregnant, and how they talked to each other in the back of the store, low, among the calico bolts, about things men did not know were being talked about. She had been a rich man in Chicago for twenty-six years and had not known one thing about it.

The first boy came in May of 1878, in the bed upstairs with the window open on the prairie. When the pains started Josef sent the hired boy on a horse for the *bába*, the midwife who had come out from Chicago that spring to keep house for her brother on Turkey Creek, because there was no doctor nearer than Crete.

The midwife came up the stairs with her bag and her sleeves already rolled, a big woman with hair the color of wheat straw, and put her hands on Marie's belly to feel how the child lay.

Marie knew her. She had known her face every night for a year. She lay on the bed with her heart going like a hammer and waited to be found out, and the midwife looked down at her with the same look she had given across the river, the look of somebody who has felt a hand on her and is deciding what it is, and said only, *Breathe, little mother. You're doing well. Breathe.*

Her name was Barbora Hájková. She had been trained in the lying-in school in Prague and had brought, she told people, nine hundred children into the world in Bohemia and Chicago before she came west. She stayed with Marie twenty hours and put the child in her arms at dawn, a boy, red and furious, and Marie looked at him and something happened to her that she had no words for in either language, that she had not felt for Jeník or for Vojta, whom she had first seen washed and wrapped and handed out the bedroom door by a nurse while she stood in the hall with a cigar.

They named him Karel. Emil came two years later, in a January blizzard, and Barbora Hájková came through the snow on horseback to deliver him, and stayed three days, and never once let on that she knew anything. Perhaps she didn't. Marie never could decide.

IV. The Window

Wilber · October 1883

THE TOWN WAS BUILDING THAT YEAR, STORES AND HOUSES AND a hall, and nearly every board of it came from the yards in Chicago. On a Tuesday in October a special freight came down the branch from Crete with thirty cars of lumber, and riding in the caboose was the man who had sold it, come out himself to see the country and collect his money.

Marie was upstairs at the front window over the store, with Emil on her hip, and saw him get down from the caboose and stand on the platform in a good coat, looking around him at the elevator and the grain wagons and the main street with that same squint he had squinted at the Irish on DeKoven Street when he was nine years old. Tomáš Pech. He had got heavier. He had a mustache.

She sent the hired girl down to the platform to say that Mrs. Kratochvíl invited the gentleman from Chicago to take coffee.

He came up the outside stairs puzzled, with his hat in his hand. She had set out coffee and a plate of koláče in the parlor with the good cups, and she gave him the chair by the stove, and sat across from him with her hands in her lap, and he was very polite to her, the way he had always been polite to women.

Madam, I never saw you before in my life, and you've been very kind. Do you know who I am?

I know very well. You live on Eighteenth Street, in Chicago, three doors from the Soukups.

That's right. You know the Soukups?

She asked after the old man, and the old woman, and Anna, and the boys, and he told her. The old man was failing. The old woman went to the cemetery every Sunday. Anna had married again, a druggist, a decent man. Jeník was ten and wanted to be an engineer on the Burlington. Vojta had his father's eyes.

And they had a son, she said. *Where is he?*

He put down his cup. *Madam, please. We drove out to the river to swim, six years ago. I turned my back to tie the horse and he was gone. They say he died at the viaduct in the strike.*

Tomáš, she said. *It's me.*

He stood up so fast the cup went over. *That's a wicked thing to say to a man. He was my friend. He was a man.*

I know. I'm him all the same. She told him about the DeKoven Street rocks and the Irish boy with the cut head, and the time they stole a whole cheese from the Bohemian picnic and ate it under the sidewalk, and he sat down again very slowly.

How?

Do you remember the woman at the ford? The big one, with her hair down?

I remember her.

I looked at her, she said, *and I thought, if she were my wife. Or if Anna looked like that. The way I thought about everything, Tomáš. Like it was for sale. And she turned around and looked at me, and it was done.*

He was quiet a long time. Emil was asleep on the horsehair sofa with his thumb in his mouth.

That was a filthy thing to think, Tomáš said at last. *Why didn't you come to me? Did you ever go to her and ask her pardon?*

I never did.

Do you know where she is?

Marie laughed then, for the first time, and wiped her eyes with the heel of her hand. *She's eight miles from here, on Turkey Creek. She delivered both my boys.*

Then have her to dinner, said Tomáš Pech, who had always known how to close a sale. *I'll do the asking.*

V. The Pardon

Wilber · the next evening

TOMÁŠ DROVE OUT TO TURKEY CREEK HIMSELF THE NEXT morning in a hired rig and found Barbora Hájková in her brother's yard boiling sheets. He took off his hat and asked her to supper at the Kratochvíls' the following day. She looked at him with her forearms red from the kettle.

You're the lumber man from Chicago. What do you want with me?

Never mind what I want, madam. Come to supper.

She came. Marie cooked for two days: roast goose and sauerkraut, bread dumplings, cucumbers in sour cream, a poppy-seed strudel, the plum preserves she had been saving since August. Josef put on his collar. The midwife sat at the head of the table, because Tomáš insisted on it, and ate like a woman who had been up two nights out of three for thirty years, which she had.

When the plates were cleared Tomáš stood. He took Marie by the hand and brought her around the table, and she knelt down on the rag rug at the midwife's feet, in front of her husband and her boys, and put her forehead on the midwife's shoe.

Paní Hájková, said Tomáš. *Forgive my friend.*

What is this?

Tomáš told her. He told it plainly, the way he would have told a man about a bad debt.

Barbora Hájková sat for a long time with her big chapped hands flat on the tablecloth. Then she leaned down and put two fingers under Marie's chin and lifted her face and looked at it. It was the third time she had looked at her like that.

I felt it, she said. *On the river. I didn't know what it was. A woman feels it, that kind of look, the way you feel a draft from a door somebody has left open behind you.* She was quiet a moment. *Get up, child. I forgive you the look.*

And Marie got up, and it was Václav who stood there.

Karel, who was five, began to scream. Josef Kratochvíl sat at the end of his own table with his napkin still tucked into his collar and did not move at all. Václav stood on the rag rug in his wife's dress, which was too short now at the wrist and the hem and too tight across the back, with his hands out a little from his sides, and the beard was rough under his palm again, and the voice that came out of him when he said *Karel, hush, it's all right, it's me,* was the voice they had buried on the first Sunday in August, six years before.

It was the midwife who went to the boy. She picked him up and held him against her shoulder until he quieted, and then she said the other thing, the one Václav would think about for the rest of his life.

Listen to me, both of you. You think it was a punishment. Being a woman. You think that was the price. She shook her head. *Nine hundred children and their mothers, and I never met one woman who was a punishment. What was done to you was only that you had to live on the other side of the look. That was all. Now you know what's over there.*

Late that night, when Tomáš had gone back to the hotel and the boys were asleep and the midwife had driven home, Josef and Václav sat on either side of the cold stove. Josef had been crying, and was not ashamed of it.

Stay, he said. *You're their mother and I'm their father. They're both of ours. Nobody here needs to know anything. Tell them you're her brother. Stay and keep the books. I can't add.*

Václav looked at his hands.

Josef. I've been a man, and then a woman, and now a man again, all in one life. I've been the father of two boys in Chicago and the mother of two here. I can't go back into a house after that. Either house. Do you understand? There's no room left in me to own anything.

He went up in the dark and kissed Karel and kissed Emil in their bed, and held each of them a long time, and came down and gave Josef the key to the store.

Take care of them. Don't you neglect them. You hear me?

In the morning he walked eight miles to Turkey Creek in a pair of Josef's trousers, and asked Barbora Hájková if she needed a man to drive her.

VI. The Buggy

Saline County · 1884–1886

SHE DID NEED ONE. SHE WAS PAST FIFTY AND THE COUNTY WAS filling up, Bohemians and Germans and Irish and Yankees, and there were nights in a hard winter when she went out to three births in a row and fell asleep on the horse. Václav drove her. He bought a black buggy with a lantern on a hook and learned every section line and creek crossing from Crete to the Kansas border, and when the knock came on the door on Turkey Creek at two in the morning he was hitching the mare before she had her boots on.

At the houses he did not go in. That was the custom and he kept it. He sat outside in the buggy with the lantern turned low, all night sometimes, in July with the mosquitoes and in January with a buffalo robe and a hot brick, and watched the one lit window, and listened.

The story had gone all over the county by the first Christmas. Bohemians are great talkers. The freethinkers at the lodge in Wilber, who did not believe in anything that could not be weighed, told it to each other over beer. People came out to Turkey Creek on Sundays to look at him. They found him in the yard mending harness and they stood at the fence and asked him straight out.

Is it true?

It's true.

Two boys in Chicago that you fathered and two boys in Wilber that you bore?

Yes.

Then which do you love more?

He would put down the harness. *The two I bore.* Every time. To everyone who asked. He could not help it, and he did not try.

That second winter Barbora Hájková began taking him in with her to the other kind of call. In the old country and in this one, the women who washed the newborn were the same women who washed the dead, and when an old man died on a claim in February it was the *bába* they sent for to lay him out. Václav carried water and held the lamp. He saw a German grandmother who had walked to Nebraska behind an ox cart lying light as a girl under the sheet. He saw a child of four dead of diphtheria in a soddy, with the frost on the inside of the walls. He saw a young farmer kicked by a mule, and the farmer's wife with her hand on the man's chest as if she could keep it going by pressing. He saw what bodies did. They came, and they changed, and changed again, and went, in the end, the same way, all of them, the ones that had been men and the ones that had been women and the ones that had not had time to be anything.

He began to drive further out on the empty nights, alone, and sit in the buggy on a rise with the reins slack and look at the dark. The midwife let him. She had given him, that first week, the only book she owned in any language, a little old Czech book in a leather cover worn white at the corners, and told him her great-great-grandmother had kept it in a hole in the wall behind the stove in a village near Litomyšl for sixty years, when owning it could cost a family its farm and its children. There was a song the exiles used to sing about it, she said, the ones who had left Bohemia for their faith, and she sang him a verse of it in the kitchen, in Czech, and then said it in English for him, because she was proud of her English.

Nothing have we taken with us,
Everything is lost;
We have but our bible of Kralice,
Our "Labyrinth of the World."

— Song of the Bohemian Exiles, in Comenius, The Labyrinth of the World, tr. Lützow

He read it in the buggy by lantern light. A pilgrim wandering the whole world, the market and the schools and the courts and the marriage beds, finding a price on everything and nothing worth it. In the spring of 1885, on a rise above the Blue, waiting outside a soddy where the midwife was sitting up with a woman who was dying in childbed and might take the child with her, he read the place where the pilgrim, at the end of everything, hears a voice call one word to him out of the dark, and call it again, and then say the rest.

Return whence thou camest to the house of the heart, and then close the doors behind thee.

— Comenius, The Labyrinth of the World and the Paradise of the Heart, ch. XXXVII

He closed the book. The lamp was lit in the soddy window and he could hear nothing. He sat a long time with his eyes shut and his hands open on his knees, and he went in, the way the book said, and closed the doors, and there was nobody in there that he owned. Not Anna. Not Jeník and Vojta. Not Karel and Emil, even. Not the gold watch or the signet ring or the four acres of lumber or the face he had been born with or the face he had been given at the ford. The house was empty and very large and he was not afraid in it.

At dawn the midwife came out of the soddy with blood to the elbow and a live child wrapped in a flour sack, and the mother was alive too, and she put the child in his arms to hold while she washed, and he held it, and he did not price it.

VII. The Lodge

Wilber · 1886

After that, when they came to the fence on Sundays and asked him, he said something else.

Which two do you love more?

I don't hold on to anybody, Václav said, and went on mending harness.

It made the lodge men angry. They argued about it at the hall in Wilber on the second Sunday of the month, after the dues were paid, and some of them went out to Turkey Creek together on a Sunday in March to have it out. They found the midwife at the kitchen table shelling beans, and Václav in the yard.

Paní Hájková, your driver is a liar. A year ago he said he loved the boys he bore. Now he says he loves nobody. A man can't say both. One of them is a lie.

The midwife went on shelling beans. Then she wiped her hands on her apron.

He isn't lying. He's changed again, that's all, and this time it didn't show. She looked at them, one after the other, farmers and a harness maker and the county treasurer's clerk, every one of whom she had either delivered or delivered the children of. *I've been at nine hundred births, gentlemen, and I'll tell you a thing. A mother can do a great deal for a child. A father can do some. Uncles and grandmothers. But there's nothing any of them can do for him that he can't do better for himself, once his mind is turned the right way round. Mine wasn't, for years. His was turned wrong the morning he saw me. Now it isn't.* She reached over to the shelf and took down the little leather book and found the page without looking, the way people find their place in a book they've read all their lives, and read it to them in Czech, and then once more in English, for Václav, who had come and was standing in the door.

> *Have a mind that is—as much as possible—lifted both upward to me and kindly downward to thy fellow-men.*
>
> *— Comenius, The Labyrinth of the World and the Paradise of the Heart, ch. LIII*

The lodge men went home. Some of them said afterward it was the most Catholic thing they had ever heard and some of them said it was the least, and they argued about that for years.

• • •

Václav Soukup drove the midwife for nineteen years, until she died, and then drove the young doctor from Crete for eleven more. He never married. He never went back to Chicago, though Tomáš Pech wrote to him every Christmas, and he never went inside the store in Wilber, though he would stop the buggy across the street on Saturdays when Karel and Emil were working the counter, two big fair young men, and they would come out and stand at the wheel and talk to him about the price of wheat. Karel named his first daughter Barbora.

The old people on the Blue who still told it, when the telling was all that was left, always ended in the same place. They said that on any night in those years, if you stood on the bluff above Turkey Creek and looked out across the dark, you could see the lit windows of the farmhouses scattered over the prairie, each one far from all the others, where somebody was being born or somebody was dying. And between them, very small and very slow, going from one to the next, you could see the one lamp moving.

Background

The verse

> *Not a mother, not a father will do so much, nor any other relative; a well-directed mind will do us greater service.*
>
> Dhammapada 43, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Soreyya, a rich man's son with a wife and two sons, drives out of his city to bathe and sees the golden-skinned elder Mahākaccāna putting on his robe at the gate. He thinks, *if only he were my wife, or my wife's body had his color,* and at once becomes a woman. Ashamed, she follows a caravan to the distant city of Takkasilā, paying her way with a signet ring, and the caravan men present her to a rich bachelor, whom she marries and bears two sons. Years later Soreyya's old com-

panion arrives with five hundred carts; she sees him from her window, tells him who she is, and he arranges a meal at which she bows at the elder's feet and is forgiven. Soreyya becomes a man again, refuses his husband's plea to stay, kisses the boys, and goes forth as a monk. Asked which sons he loves more, he says at first the ones he bore; after a time alone contemplating decay and death, he says his affections are set on no one, and when the monks call this a lie the Buddha speaks the verse. The commentary frames the change as the fruit of an unwise thought and repeats its age's view that rebirth as a woman is the lesser lot; this retelling keeps the change and its cause and lets the midwife answer that view. Read the full commentary story.

Chicago, Illinois, and Wilber, Nebraska

Chicago and the Big Blue, 1877–1886

The Great Railroad Strike of 1877 began in West Virginia on July 14 and reached Chicago the following week. On July 25 a crowd of about ten thousand gathered at the Halsted Street viaduct; police fired into it for half an hour, cavalry came up afterward, and some thirty people were killed in what was called the Battle of the Viaduct. The true toll was never settled, since many bodies were reportedly buried at night. The same year Chicago's Czechs, angered when a young Catholic woman, Marie Silhanek, was refused burial in Catholic ground, bought land in Jefferson Township for the Bohemian National Cemetery, a place where anyone could be buried without a priest's leave. The Czech West Side, later centered on Pilsen, was home to many freethinkers, lodges and gymnastic societies.

Many Chicago Czechs moved on to the Nebraska prairie. Wilber, on the Big Blue River in Saline County, was platted in 1873, became the county seat in 1878, and by 1882 had a Czech benevolent lodge meeting in the Masons' hall on the second Sunday of every month; it is now called the Czech capital of the United States. The book the midwife keeps is The Labyrinth of the World and the Paradise of the Heart (first version 1623) by John Amos Comenius, the last bishop of the Unity of the Brethren, the old Czech Protestant church that was driven underground and into ex-

ile after 1620. The quotations, and the exiles' song, come from Count Lützow's 1901 English translation, which is online.

After the story of the Elder Soreyya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 43). The original. Scripture from John Amos Comenius, *The Labyrinth of the World and the Paradise of the Heart*, tr. Count Lützow (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 4

Flowers

4.1

The Stone Crop

The human mind is like soil which is such as it is made by cultivation.
— Swedenborg, Heaven and Hell 356

This is the way I had it, on the Black River in the Reserve.

I. Stony Loam

Lyme Hollow, Windsor County, Vermont · June 1816 to May 1817

> No. 1. Our own. A brown loam on a hard pan, thin on the hills, better in the hollow. Full of stones of every size from a hen's egg to a cart. The stones come up anew every spring with the frost and must be picked, and are laid in walls. No man living has seen the bottom of them.
>
> — A. Pettengill, clerk

It snowed on the seventh and eighth of June. Asa Pettengill was nineteen and kept the district school, and he walked out on the morning of the eighth to see the corn, and the corn was lying flat and black in rows, and the snow lay in the furrows between, and the birds that had come north for the summer were sitting on the stone walls with their feathers puffed out, and some of them were dead in the grass. Frost again in July. Frost on the twenty-first of August that took the beans. By September the town was eating its seed.

That winter the men met in the meetinghouse, which had no stove, and agreed to go. Thirty-one families. They would sell what they could and go together to a township in the Connecticut Reserve that a man from Bennington had for sale, all of it, and lay it out in lots by drawing,

and build a meetinghouse first. They would take their minister if he would come. He would not. They took their deacon and their militia captain and the oldest person in the hollow, who was the Widow Submit Haskell, who had buried two husbands and seven of her eleven children and would not be left behind.

Because the deacon and the captain could not agree which of them should judge the land along the way, they gave the job to the schoolmaster, who had a good hand, and told him to set down every soil they passed over from Lyme Hollow to the Reserve, so that the company would know what was good and what was not. He bought a blank book in Windsor for that purpose for one and six. It is the book these entries are taken from.

The deacon was Ezra Wetherbee and the captain was Jonas Lamb, and their farms had shared a wall for twenty-two years, and for nineteen of them they had not agreed about it. Every spring the frost lifted stones out of the ground on both sides, and every spring each man threw his own stones on the wall, and each man said the other threw his over. In 1809 it went to the justice. In 1811 it went to the church, where the deacon could not sit in judgment on his own case and sat anyway. They sold both farms to the same man from Massachusetts in the same week and walked out of the hollow on the same morning, in May of 1817, one at the head of the wagons and one at the tail.

The Widow Haskell rode in Lamb's wagon on a feather bed with a box in her lap. In the box were her husband's spectacles, a paper of seeds, and a London book called *Heaven and Hell*, which her second husband, a tin peddler, had taken in trade at Boston for a coffee pot and a lantern and never read. She had read it eleven times. The deacon would not sit in the same room with it.

II. Flats

The Mohawk below Little Falls, New York · June 1817

> No. 9. The German Flats. A black mould of the river, deep, without one stone in it that I could find, though Capt. Lamb walked into a field to look and was spoke to sharply in Dutch. Grass to a man's belt.

> Wheat very good. The Dutchmen here have been on it a hundred years and say the river gives it back every spring.

That was the first time the men talked soil at night. They had been talking about it all day walking, but that night at the fire they talked about nothing else, and after that it was every night. The flats were a wonder to them. Captain Lamb held up a fist of that black ground and let it go through his fingers, and nothing stayed in his palm, not a pebble, and some of the men laughed out loud.

The widow did not get down from the wagon. She sat on the tailboard with her feet hanging and her book shut on her knee, and she looked at the river.

III. Openings

The Genesee Road, beyond Canandaigua · June 1817

> No. 14. Oak openings. A light sand or gravel, the trees standing apart like an orchard, and grass between. Easy to break, they say, and easy to lose. The Holland Company's men at Batavia say it will bear wheat. Deacon W. says sand is sand.
>
> No. 15. The same, wetter. Even and uneven.

Every wagon on the Genesee Road was going the same way. They passed Vermonters and New Hampshire men and a whole congregation from Connecticut with its minister riding in front on a white mare, and every one of them was talking soil. At the taverns in the evening the men stood in the yard with their hats on the backs of their heads and argued gravel and sand and clay and muck. A man from Rutland said there was land in the Indiana country where you could push a ramrod in to the thimble. A man from Pittsfield said the Reserve was all clay and the clay held water like a pan and the water bred the fever. The deacon said there was no land on earth without a fault in it, and looked at the captain when he said it.

Asa wrote it all down. In the back of the book he began a list of the things people told him, which ran to four pages and contradicted itself on every one.

IV. Mud

The lake road, Buffalo to the Pennsylvania line · late June 1817

> No. 22. Black ash swamp. Mud.
>
> No. 23. Mud.
>
> No. 24. A red clay like the inside of a brick, then mud. Lost the Wetherbees' near ox in it to the belly. Got him out. Six days from Buffalo, which the British burnt in the war.

The road along the lake was a cut through the woods with the stumps left in it, and where it was not stumps it was mud, and where it was not mud it was sand that the wheels went into to the felloes. When the deacon's ox went down in the red clay at a creek east of Erie, the men of the company hauled him out with chains, and the captain put his shoulder under the yoke with the rest, and nobody said anything about it afterward, and it seemed to Asa that the two men had been given something to talk about that was not the wall, and that neither of them would take it.

It rained eleven days of the fourteen. The widow was wet through, and her book was wrapped in an oilcloth inside her dress, and she did not complain once that anybody heard. The children walked beside her wagon because she would tell them things. She told them that every bird that sang had a reason, and that the angels in heaven wove crowns of flowers for children who had died small, and that her own four were wearing them, and that the crowns did not fade. One of the Lamb girls said there were no flowers in a swamp. The widow leaned down and picked one off the edge of the cut, a little white thing on a long stem with a drop of rain in it, and gave it to her, and said, *That was there all the time.*

V. Black Clay and Red

The township, on the east branch of the Black River · July 1817

> No. 31. Our own again. A stiff yellow clay under beech and maple, very heavy, with a black mould on top of it about four inches deep where the leaves have lain. In the swales a black clay that will stick a boot. On the ridge toward the river a red clay with gravel in it. Abounds in mud at present. NOT ONE STONE.

He wrote the last three words in capitals and underlined them twice, and that is how they are in the book.

The tract had been signed away at Fort Industry twelve years before by the Wyandot and the Ottawa and the others who had used it, and in the beech woods there were still the bark frames of hunting camps falling in, and along the river old cornhills under the grass that nobody in the company could account for. Asa wrote them down too, and did not know under what heading.

They drew lots on the second Sunday, out of the deacon's hat. The deacon drew the lot on the river and the captain drew the lot beside it, and the company stood in the clearing and heard it and was still. Somebody laughed. Then the captain walked to the line between the two lots, where the surveyor's blaze was on a beech, and stood there, and then he got down on his knees and began to dig at the clay with his hands, and the whole company watched him do it. He dug down a forearm's length. He sat back on his heels and held his hands up, yellow to the wrist, and there was nothing in them.

Well, Ezra, he said. *There's nothing here to throw.*

It was the first thing he had said to the deacon direct in six years. The deacon did not answer it.

VI. The Inner Soil

Captain Lamb's cabin, the first Sabbath evening in August 1817

> No. 32. This entry is not a soil. I set it down because I was asked to.

The first roof in the township was the captain's, so the company met under it. It had no floor yet. They sat on the sills and on blocks of beech and on the ground, the men on one side and the women on the other, and the children in the door, and they read the psalm and prayed, the deacon praying, since there was no minister. When the prayer was done nobody went home. It was hot and the mosquitoes were bad and outside it was raining again on the clay. The men began to talk.

They talked about the yellow clay and whether it would drain if you ditched it. They talked about the black clay in the swales and whether that was where the fever came from. They talked about the red clay on the ridge and the gravel in it. They talked about the flats on the Mohawk and the openings on the Genesee and the man from Rutland and his ramrod. They talked about even land and uneven, and land that abounded in mud, and land that abounded in gravel, and Asa, who had the book open on his knee because they kept asking him what number this was and what number that, saw that they were reading the whole road back to one another from the beginning, every mile of it, and that they would go on reading it all night.

The Widow Haskell had been sitting by the cold hearth with her hands on her box. She asked them, in her little high voice, what it was that they were all talking about.

Captain Lamb said, *The soils, Mother. What we saw on the road.*

She was quiet a while. Then she said, *You came out of Lyme Hollow because the ground grew stones.*

They said yes.

And you have looked in every field from there to here. And you have found the one without a stone in it.

They said yes, that was so, and somebody said, *Praise God,* and the deacon said, *Amen.*

I have had a wall to the north of me for sixty years, said the widow. *Ezra knows it, he helped my first husband lay it. You can stand on the wall in March and see the stones come up in the field like bread. Where do you suppose they come from? Nobody puts them in. They are in it. The frost goes into the ground and finds them and lifts them up one at a time, and the ground is no worse ground for it. It is only that they are let out.*

She opened the box and took out the book in its oilcloth and did not open it. She knew the place.

> *The human mind is like soil which is such as it is made by cultivation.*
>
> *— Swedenborg, Heaven and Hell 356*

You have every one of you brought your stones, she said. *I watched you load them. They are in the wagons under the feather beds. They will come up the first hard frost, every one, and you will have to pick them, and you had better not throw them on your neighbor.*

Nobody said anything at all. The rain came through the roof in one place and fell on the ground between the deacon and the captain, a little stream of it, and made a hole in the clay.

This is the soil you have to know, said the widow. *Not that one. You will learn that one with an ax in two years. This one you will be all your life at, and all the way to the other side, and past it. There is a garden there. I have read about it.* She put the book in the box. *Pick what is good out of it, the way you would pick the one flower. You can leave the rest by the road.*

> *There the intelligent walk, and gather flowers and weave garlands with which they adorn little children.*
>
> *— Swedenborg, Heaven and Hell 176*

Then she asked the captain to carry her to bed, because she was tired, and he did.

• • •

That is the end of the soil book. After entry thirty-two there are only Asa Pettengill's school accounts for the winter of 1817 and 1818, and on the last page, in a different ink, a note that the frost came on the eighteenth of November and went down deep, and that in March the clay heaved like a loaf, and that nothing came up out of it.

It was said in the township for a hundred years afterward, by people who could not have known, that every soul who sat under that roof went home that night and was changed, the whole company at once, and that not one of them in the rest of their lives went to law against another. The church records, which begin in 1819, do not contradict it.

The Widow Haskell died in April of 1818, the first death in the township, and was buried on the ridge in the red clay. The day of the burying the spring beauties were out under the beeches, white with a pink vein in them, more than anyone had ever seen, and the women picked them all morning and wove them into a crown, and it was laid on the coffin by Ezra Wetherbee's granddaughter, who was six, standing on a block, with Jonas Lamb's hand under her elbow so she would not fall.

Background

The verses

> *Who shall overcome this earth, and the world of Yama (the lord of the departed), and the world of the gods? Who shall find out the plainly shown path of virtue, as a clever man finds out the (right) flower?*
>
> Dhammapada 44, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The disciple will overcome the earth, and the world of Yama, and the world of the gods. The disciple will find out the plainly shown path of virtue, as a clever man finds out the (right) flower.*
>
> Dhammapada 45, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Five hundred monks come back to Jetavana from a journey through the countryside with the Buddha and sit in the hall talking about the ground they walked over: even and uneven, muddy, gravelly, black clay, red clay. The Buddha asks what they are discussing, tells them that this is the outer soil and that they must clear the soil within, and speaks the two verses, which turn on the double sense of "earth" and on the gar-

land-maker who knows which flower to pick. All five hundred are said to have reached awakening as he finished. Read the full commentary story. The teacher's book is *Heaven and Hell* (1758) by Emanuel Swedenborg, a work "from things heard and seen" in which earth, heaven and hell answer one another by correspondence; it is quoted here in John C. Ager's translation.

Black River, Western Reserve, Ohio

Vermont and the Reserve, 1816–1818

The eruption of Tambora in April 1815 brought the Year Without a Summer to New England. Frost killed crops on the high ground in May 1816; snow fell across the region on June 6 to 8; killing frosts came again in August. The historian L. D. Stillwell estimated that Vermont lost ten to fifteen thousand people to emigration in 1816 and 1817, many of them bound for western New York and Ohio. The New England hill farms they left were notorious for stones: frost heaving lifts glacial cobbles to the surface every spring, and the miles of stone walls in Vermont were built largely from what farmers picked off their fields.

The northern route west ran up the Mohawk, out the Genesee Road through the lands of the Holland Land Company at Batavia, through Buffalo (burned by the British in December 1813), and along the lake shore into the Connecticut Western Reserve, sold by Connecticut to the Connecticut Land Company in 1796. Title west of the Cuyahoga, where this story's fictional township lies, was taken from the Wyandot, Ottawa and other nations at the Treaty of Fort Industry in 1805. Whole New England congregations often moved and settled together, laying out a new town by lot.

After the story of the five hundred monks who talked about soil, from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 44 and 45). The original. Scripture from Swedenborg's Heaven and Hell, tr. John C. Ager. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

4.2

Notional Water

> *The thirsty one supposeth it to be water till he cometh unto it and findeth it naught, and findeth, in the place thereof, Allah Who payeth him his due*
> — *Qur'an 24:39*

Hīch sima'it, in the Box.

I. The Lane

Medina Nahr, Fort Irwin, California · July 2008

Medina Nahr means River Town, and there has never been a river within sixty miles of it. The Army built it in the Mojave Desert out of shipping containers faced with plaster the color of dust: a police station, a clinic, a hotel with no beds, a row of shops, a mosque with a plywood minaret and a loudspeaker that worked. For two weeks out of every month it had people. They came up from San Diego and El Cajon on a contractor's bus, Iraqis nearly all of them, and each was handed a card with a name that was not his name, and a trade, and a tribe, and an opinion of the Americans. They slept in trailers behind the false fronts and were the town's butcher and its mayor and its widows until the bus took them home.

The Army had a word for all of it. The word was notional. It meant a thing that existed for the purposes of the exercise. There was notional water in the water tower and a notional sheikh in the big house, and by the end of any afternoon there were notional dead in the street, who lay where they fell until a horn blew.

Specialist Hayder Jassim was a medic in an infantry company that had come out from Kansas to be taught, in three weeks, the country where he

had been born. His name tape said JASSIM. The platoon called him Doc, as platoons call every medic. He was twenty. In October the battalion was going to Diyala for a year.

Every soldier in the Box wore a harness of laser sensors over his armor and a ring of them around his helmet. When a blank round or a buried charge found him, the harness screamed, one flat tone that went on until somebody with authority shut it off. In his pocket he carried a sealed card that told him, when the time came, what his wound was. The men with authority were the observer-controllers, sergeants in soft caps who walked through the fighting untouched and wrote things down. Each had on his belt a gray plastic thing like a child's pistol that could kill a harness from across a street or bring it back to life. The Army had some long name for that too. Everybody in the Box, privates and colonels, called it the god gun.

On the second day in the lanes a car went up in the market. It was a propane charge and a drum of something that made black smoke, and when the smoke lifted there were six people down among the plywood fruit. Hayder's was a man by the tea stall whose left leg ended above the knee.

The leg did end there. The contractor hired amputees. Over the stump the man wore a sleeve of silicone with a white knob of bone in it and a tube that pumped red syrup each time he squeezed a bulb in his fist, and he was squeezing it, and he was screaming for his mother in Arabic.

Hayder knelt in the syrup and got the tourniquet out of his bag, and his hands would not do it. He had put that tourniquet on his own thigh in the dark at Fort Sam Houston in under forty seconds. Now the strap went through the buckle the wrong way, and then the right way, and he could not find the windlass with his fingers though he was looking straight at it. The syrup was warm. The scream was in the accent of his mother's kitchen. Sergeant First Class Dunn stood over him with a clipboard, counting under his breath, and at some number he stopped counting and pointed the god gun at the man on the ground.

He's bled out, Doc. Move to your next one.

Across the street an old man sat on an upturned crate under the awning of the tea stall. He had not moved when the car went up and he did not move now. The card around his neck said HAJJI SABAH, TEA SELLER, 70, NEUTRAL. He was watching Hayder's hands the way a teacher watches a boy at the blackboard.

• • •

When the lane was over the horn blew and the dead got up. The man with one leg unstrapped his wound, hung it on the fruit stall, and lit a cigarette. Somebody ran a garden hose over the gravel. Hayder sat on the curb with his aid bag between his boots, and after a while a small glass of tea came down in front of his face, real tea, black, with cardamom in it.

Whose son are you? the old man said, in the Arabic of the south.

Jassim Abd al-Zahra's. From Nasiriyah.

And where did Jassim's son learn to sit on a curb like a refugee?

Rafha.

The old man lowered himself onto the curb beside him, which took some time. His name off the card was Kadhim. He had been a schoolmaster at Suq al-Shuyukh for thirty-one years, and in March of 1991, when the rising in the south was put down, he had walked across the border with what he had on. He had spent six years behind the wire at Rafha, in the Saudi desert, with thirty thousand others. He had kept a school there in a tent, with a square of canvas painted black for a board.

Then perhaps I had you, he said. *I had four hundred of you. They shaved all your heads for the lice and I never could tell one from another.*

Hayder had come out of Rafha at seven, to Lincoln, Nebraska, where it snowed. He remembered a black square with white letters on it and a stick that pointed.

He had not meant to say anything. He said it into the tea glass. That his hands had been good until today. That in October it would be the real one. That his father had stopped praying somewhere over the Atlantic and he himself had only his mother's prayers, by ear, like a song in a language he half knew. That he did not know what a man was supposed to

do with this much fear and nobody in his chain of command seemed to think it was a medical question.

Ustadh. Give me something to do.

The old man looked at him for a long time. Then he took from the pocket of his vest a string of clay beads, a hundred of them, small and gray-brown, the clay of Karbala, worn dark and smooth as apple seeds.

You know the night prayer? Your mother's will do. After it, go where nobody is. One bead, one breath. On the breath out, lā ilāha. *On the breath in,* illā Allāh. *Nothing else goes with it. When you have it, come and tell me.*

II. Twelve Nights

The Central Corridor

THE COMPANY WENT OUT INTO THE DESERT THE NEXT MORNing and did not see a building for twelve days. The Box is a thousand square miles of gravel and creosote bush with brown mountains standing up out of it like the backs of animals, and a regiment lives there whose only work is to be the enemy. They came at dawn out of the sun and at dusk out of the dust. By the fourth day half the battalion had been killed twice and brought back by the god gun so it could be killed again.

At night, when the aid station was quiet, Hayder walked out past the last vehicle to where nobody was. He found a flat stone. He stood and faced a little east of north, because from California the shortest way to Mecca goes up over the top of the world, and he said the night prayer as his mother said it, with his forehead on the stone, since he had no tablet of clay to put it on. Then he sat down on his heels and took out the beads.

He did it the way he did everything the Army had taught him, which was hard. The first night he went around the string once and his mind went around the Box eleven times. The second night he went around five times. By the sixth night he was doing three thousand breaths between midnight and stand-to, with his thumbnail white on the clay. Nothing else goes with it, the old man had said, and everything went with it. The man by the tea stall went with it, screaming, and the strap going through the buckle the wrong way. His mother went with it, standing at the sink

in Lincoln. His father went with it, who had driven a truck for the rising in Nasiriyah for nine days in 1991 and had not said one sentence about it since, and who boxed parts on the night shift and slept through the day with a towel over the window. October went with it. He would get to forty beads and find he had been counting days.

He tried holding the breath at the top. He tried sitting until his feet went dead. One night he fell asleep upright and dreamed the beads were teeth and woke with his jaw clenched.

On the twelfth night he went around the string once, slowly, and put it in his pocket.

He did not think the old man had given him a bad thing. He thought it was a good thing made for somebody else, the way a boot can be a good boot and not your size. *I'll go back,* he thought. *I'll tell him I couldn't, and ask him for one that fits.* He felt easier than he had in twelve days, having decided that, and slept three hours on the gravel with his helmet for a pillow.

III. The Lake

The dry lake · the thirteenth day, 1300 *hours*

The order came at breakfast. The last fight of the rotation would be for Medina Nahr, and the company would go in on foot, nine kilometers across the dry lake, because the vehicles had been notionally destroyed the day before and nobody had the authority to bring a vehicle back.

A dry lake is the flattest thing there is. The water that made it has been gone some thousands of years, and it left a floor of pale clay cracked into plates the size of dinner trays, level to the horizon, without a stone on it. They stepped off at noon. It was a hundred and nine degrees. Each man had six quarts of water on him and drank on the hour whether he wanted to or not.

Around one o'clock the lake filled.

It came in from the west, quietly, a long bright sheet of it, blue and then silver, with a clean shore. Medina Nahr rose out of the far side. The

minaret stood up white, and under it a second minaret hung down into the water, and the hotel with no beds floated a little off the ground with daylight under it. There were palm trees. There are no palm trees at Medina Nahr.

Well, look at that, somebody said behind him. *River Town got its river.*

They all knew what it was. They walked toward it anyway, since that was the direction, and it kept its distance. Every step they took, the shore drew back one step. Where the water had been a minute ago there was clay, and their boots, and the white dust their boots put up.

Hayder had seen this lake before. At Rafha it had come every afternoon in the hot months, outside the wire to the north, and the small boys had run to the fence to see if it was any closer today. His mother told him it was the Euphrates. She said the river had not forgotten them and was showing itself so they would know. He had believed her until he was six, and after that he had gone on running to the fence.

He watched it now as he had been told to watch his breath, and for the first time in thirteen days nothing else went with it.

From far off it had a shore and a color and a town standing in it. A man could swear to it in court. Close up there was no place where it stopped being water and started being ground. It simply was never where you were. He thought of the town itself, the real one over there under the false one, which from here was a town and from inside was forty steel boxes and a horn. He thought of the leg by the tea stall. He thought of Nasiriyah, which he had carried for thirteen years in Nebraska as a place with streets and a river and a house in it, and which in October he would walk up to with his boots on.

Then he thought of the one who was doing the thinking. Doc. Jassim's son. The one with the hands. He had been carrying that one a long time too, and it had looked solid enough from wherever he was standing. It had been born in a certain room and it was older now than it had been at the last halt. He tried to walk up to it. He could not find the place where it began.

He went the next four kilometers like that, looking. Some way back his thumb had stopped moving on the beads in his pocket, and he had not noticed.

IV. The Wash

East of Medina Nahr · 1540 hours

In July the clouds build over those mountains every afternoon, and most afternoons that is all they do. This time they went black on the bottom, and a gray curtain came down on the high ground to the south and stood there for twenty minutes. No rain fell on the company. They smelled it, wet dust and creosote, which is the best smell in that country.

Past the edge of the lake bed there was a wash to cross, a gully of sand and round stones ten meters wide that had been dry since anybody's map was drawn. They heard it before they got there. It was running bank to bank, brown as cocoa and louder than a truck, with whole bushes going by in it.

The captain looked at it. The controllers looked at it and got on their radios, and the word came down the line that the war was paused for safety, that the water was real, and that anybody who went in it would answer to the sergeant major. The company sat down along the bank in its harnesses and waited for the desert to finish.

Hayder went down to the edge. A little upstream a shelf of rock ran across the wash, and the flood came over it and fell about the height of a man's knee. He took off his gloves and his helmet. He washed his face in the brown water, and his arms to the elbow, and wiped his wet hand over his head and over the tops of his boots, since the boots were not coming off. It was cold. It had been in the sky a half hour ago.

Then he sat on his heels on the wet sand and looked at the place below the shelf.

Where the water struck, it made foam. The foam stood in a heap at the foot of the rock, tan and white, as big as a footlocker, shaking a little. He would have said it was a thing. He looked closer and it was bubbles, some

the size of a pea and some the size of his fist, and one that swelled up as big as a helmet. Each of them had the whole sky in it, bent, and a very small soldier squatting on a bank. Each one rode out from the rock a hand's breadth, or an arm's length, and was gone, and the place where it had been closed over. The heap stayed. Not one bubble in it was the same as when he sat down.

It's made like this, he thought. *And it breaks like this.*

He looked up the bank at the company. A hundred and twenty men sat in the sun with their helmets off, each with a sealed card in his pocket. He looked at his own hands, which were wet and perfectly still. He looked for a long while at the foam, at the swelling and the riding out and the closing over, and he stopped looking for anything in it that would stay long enough to be afraid for.

V. The Tea Stall

Medina Nahr · the same hour

Four kilometers west the town was being set for its last battle. Men from the contractor were burying charges in the market. The mayor was going over his lines. A young woman from El Cajon named Nadia, who played a widow and had done it for nine rotations, was pinning her scarf in the side mirror of a notional taxi beside the tea stall, and she told the rest of this afterward to anybody who asked and several who did not.

The stall was a plywood counter and an awning. The old man kept a kettle on a propane ring there and a jar of cardamom pods with the lid off, and you could smell it the length of the street. He was sitting on his crate with his hands on his knees. Nadia said he lifted his head and looked east over the roofs, toward where the sky was dark, the way you look across a road at somebody you know. Then he spoke, loudly, in the voice he must have used on four hundred boys.

Hajji, she said, *who are you talking to?*

A student, he said. He poured a glass of tea, set it on the counter, and left it there.

At the wash Hayder heard it at his right shoulder. It was plain and close over the noise of the water, and it was in the Arabic of Suq al-Shuyukh.

Yes, my son. That is it. Like the foam and like the sarāb. *That is exactly how it is made, and that is exactly how it goes.*

And then the voice recited, as a schoolmaster recites, so that it can be taken down.

> *As for those who disbelieve, their deeds are as a mirage in a desert. The thirsty one supposeth it to be water till he cometh unto it and findeth it naught, and findeth, in the place thereof, Allah Who payeth him his due; and Allah is swift at reckoning.*
>
> *— Qur'an 24:39*

> *He sendeth down water from the sky, so that valleys flow according to their measure, and the flood beareth (on its surface) swelling foam - from that which they smelt in the fire in order to make ornaments and tools riseth a foam like unto it - thus Allah coineth (the similitude of) the true and the false. Then, as for the foam, it passeth away as scum upon the banks, while, as for that which is of use to mankind, it remaineth in the earth. Thus Allah coineth the similitudes.*
>
> *— Qur'an 13:17*

Hayder did not turn around. He knew there was nobody at his shoulder. He stayed on his heels by the water and felt for the fear, the way a man pats his pocket for his wallet, and it was not in that pocket or any other. He felt for the one who had been afraid. There was the wash, and the shelf of rock, and the foam being made and going.

Something was finished. He knew it the way you know a tooth is out. Whatever a man is sent into the desert to do, he had done it at the edge of a ditch in the time it takes a company to smoke.

The flood dropped as fast as it had come. In forty minutes it was to the ankle. The controllers gave the war back, and the company went across on wet stones, and behind them the foam lay stranded along both banks in dirty lines, ticking.

VI. Endex

Medina Nahr · dusk

They came into the town at sundown, and it went the way those things go. There were mortar simulators and a machine gun on the hotel roof, and a second car in the market, bigger than the first. Every harness in second platoon began to scream at once.

Hayder's did not. He noticed this and put it aside, because the man with one leg was down by the fruit stall again in the same place, pumping syrup and calling for his mother.

The tourniquet went on in the time it takes to say so. Hayder's hands did it and he watched them do it. He told the man in Arabic that he had him, and then, since the man was from Lakeside and had lost the leg on a motorcycle, he told him again in English, and the man stopped screaming for a second and looked up at him with interest. Hayder marked the time on the man's forehead with a grease pencil and went on to the next one, and the one after. He was not calm the way you are calm when you are holding something down. There was nothing to hold down. He knelt in the syrup among the screaming harnesses and it was a street and some people and what his hands knew.

Sergeant First Class Dunn came through with his clipboard and stopped. He looked at Hayder's harness, which had a small green light on it and was silent. He looked at the crater, which was three meters away.

You're dead, Doc.

It didn't go off, Sergeant.

Dunn unhooked the god gun from his belt and pointed it at the middle of Hayder's chest and squeezed. Nothing. He took one step closer and squeezed again. He checked something on the side of the gun, pointed it at a private sitting against the wall, whose harness went off like a smoke alarm, turned that one off, and pointed it at Hayder a third time.

The green light stayed green. Dunn had been a controller for three years and had killed colonels with that gun.

Well, he said finally. *I can't find you. Carry on.* And he wrote something on the clipboard, and looked at it, and crossed it out.

• • •

The horn blew at full dark. End of exercise. All down the street the dead sat up and felt for their cigarettes, and somebody turned on the hose.

The glass of tea was still on the counter of the stall. It was cold and had a skin of dust on it. Hayder drank it standing. Then he took the old man's right hand in both of his and kissed it and touched it to his forehead, which he had seen his father do once, to an uncle, in a tent.

He held out the beads.

Keep them, the old man said. *Did you ever get to a hundred?*

No, Ustadh. I never did.

No, the old man said. He seemed pleased. He looked up the street, where the widows were laughing and a boy was rolling up the hose, and he said the rest quietly, to no one in particular.

> *Everyone that is thereon will pass away;*
> *There remaineth but the Countenance of thy Lord of Might and Glory.*
>
> *— Qur'an 55:26–27*

The buses came for the townspeople at noon the next day. The company rode out an hour behind them in the backs of trucks, along the edge of the dry lake, with their harnesses in a pile on the floor.

The lake was back. It lay out blue to the foot of the mountains, with a clean shore. Medina Nahr stood in it up to its doorsills with nobody inside, and the minaret hung down under itself, and the trucks went along beside the water for an hour and never got a tire wet.

Background

The verse

> *He who knows that this body is like froth, and has learnt that it is as unsubstantial as a mirage, will break the flower-pointed arrow of Mara, and never see the king of death.*
>
> Dhammapada 46, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest in the collection. A monk takes a meditation subject from the Buddha and goes into the forest, strives hard, and gets nowhere. He sets out to ask for a subject that suits him better. On the road he sees a mirage and takes that as his subject; then, tired, he bathes in the river Aciravatī and sits by a waterfall watching bubbles of foam form and burst, and takes that. The Buddha, seated far away in his Perfumed Chamber, sees him and says, "It is even so," and speaks the verse, and the monk is freed where he sits. Read the full commentary story. The same pair of images, foam and mirage, stands side by side in the Qur'an, in the two verses the schoolmaster recites.

Fort Irwin, California

Fort Irwin, 2008

The National Training Center at Fort Irwin covers about a thousand square miles of the Mojave Desert north of Barstow, California. Visiting brigades fight a resident opposing force there, and laser sensors (the MILES system) register who has been hit. During the Iraq war the Army built a dozen or so mock Iraqi towns in "the Box," first from garden sheds, then from shipping containers, later from masonry; the Army's own account of one such village dates from 2008. Contractors bused in Iraqi Americans, many from the San Diego area, to live in the towns during each rotation and play mayors, police, shopkeepers and mourners, alongside amputee actors fitted with simulated wounds. The 2008 documentary *Full Battle Rattle* was filmed in the best known of these towns, Medina Wasl. Medina Nahr and everyone in it are invented. "Notional" is the Army's ordinary word for anything simulated in an exercise, and the observer-controllers' handheld device for killing and resetting a soldier's sensor harness really is called the god gun.

After the 1991 Gulf War, Shia in southern Iraq rose against Saddam Hussein's government; the uprisings were crushed within weeks, and tens of thousands fled across the Saudi border. Saudi Arabia held them in a closed desert camp near Rafha, under guard and curfew, for more than a decade. Roughly half of those who were resettled abroad from Rafha went to the United States before the American program ended in

1997, according to the U.S. Committee for Refugees; communities grew in Dearborn, San Diego, Lincoln, Nebraska, and elsewhere. Twelver Shia commonly pray with the forehead resting on earth or a small tablet of clay from Karbala, and count remembrance on clay beads. From California the direction of Mecca is northeast, over the Arctic.

After the story of the elder who meditated on a mirage, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 46). The original. Scripture from *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran*, tr. Marmaduke Pickthall (1930). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

4·3

Thin Shade

> *Then two shall be in the field: one shall be taken, and one shall be left.*
> *— Matthew 24:40*

Así lo oí contar, on the river road below Esperanza.

I. The Cane

San Antonio and Laredo · the 1850s

Three boys met on the steps of the Brothers' school in San Antonio the autumn it opened, and asked each other where they were from and who their people were, and by Christmas they were friends. Ambrose Rourke was from Tennessee by way of the war with Mexico, which had brought his father to Texas and killed him there. Tomás Leal was from Laredo. Sixto Benavides was from Laredo too, from the other end of it, and could already ride anything with hair on it. They learned their Latin and their surveying and their sums together, and when they were finished they shook hands at the stage office and went home.

Ambrose Rourke went down to the river country and read law and surveyed land, and the land he surveyed had a way of becoming his, and by thirty he was the county judge at Esperanza and by forty there was nothing in that county that moved without his knowing.

Tomás Leal opened a school for the sons of the good families of Laredo and worked over his books by lamplight until his eyes failed him. The families said they would not turn their teacher out for that, and they gave him the toll from the river ferry for his living, and he sat by the

landing all the rest of his life in a cane chair, blind, teaching boys their Latin by ear and telling every wagon by the sound of its wheels.

As for Sixto Benavides, the young men of his family set him a test at the fiesta of San Agustín. They tied river cane in bundles of sixty stalks, hung sixty bundles from a beam, and told him to cut them through with a saber from horseback at a gallop. He cut the first fifty-nine without a sound. At the sixtieth he heard a click, and pulled up, and found the iron rod they had hidden inside every bundle.

He threw the saber in the dirt and wept in front of all of them. *Not one of you,* he said, *not one of my own blood thought enough of me to tell me. If I'd known, I'd have cut them so the iron never rang.* He told his father he would kill every one of those cousins. His father talked him out of it over three nights. Then Sixto said, *Then I'll go to my friend,* and saddled his horse and rode to Esperanza, and Judge Rourke met him on the road and made him chief deputy of the county that same week.

II. The Plate

Esperanza, Texas · 1879

In those years Doña Natividad Romero lived in a jacal of mesquite pickets on the river road with her nephew Chencho, and the sick came to her from both sides of the river. She was a cousin of the Romeros of Rancho Santa Rita, who had held their land along the Rio Grande since the King of Spain's surveyors set their stone in 1767, and who did not let anybody forget it. She had left that house young and never gone back to live in it. She set bones, she prayed over fevers, she knew every plant in the brush, and she said very little. The women who learned from her went out every morning, two by two, to the ranches where they were wanted.

Judge Rourke watched them go by his gallery. They went to the Peñas, the Ramírezes, the Garzas, never to him. He sent word that the señoras were welcome at his table any day of the week, and for a week they came, and he served them himself, and on the eighth day he had business at the courthouse and forgot them. Nobody else in that house would set a chair

for them without being told. The next day he forgot them again, and the next, and by the end of the week the only one who still came was Chencho, who sat alone at the long table and ate what was put in front of him because his aunt had told him to.

The Judge rode out to the jacal angry. *I set a table for twelve, and your nephew came.*

Doña Natividad did not blame her women. *They go where they're met at the gate,* she said. *Where somebody sets them a chair and gives them the good coffee and doesn't hide the sugar. Where somebody sits down and listens. They don't stay where nobody does.* And then she told him a story, the way she answered most things, about an old man who fell sick in a rich house and did not get well there, though the doctors came from Monterrey, and who got well in a week in a brush camp among his own people, eating wild greens without salt. *Because where you eat with confidence,* she said, *confidence is the best taste there is.*

The Judge rode home thinking about it. He thought: if I want them to trust this house, I'll bring her people into it. And he sent to Rancho Santa Rita asking Don Mariano Romero for one of his daughters.

The Romeros sat down together in the long sala at Santa Rita. *The man is our enemy,* they said. *If we refuse him he'll have our land in the courts in five years. And he isn't our equal. What do we do?* Don Mariano said: *I have a daughter. Valentina. Her mother is Pilar, in the kitchen. She is the most beautiful girl on this river. We'll give him her.*

Nobody at Santa Rita had ever asked who Pilar's people were or how she had come to the ranch as a child. It was not a thing that was asked.

The Judge was no fool. *Those Romeros would sell me a cook's child in a lace veil,* he told the men he sent. *Don't bring her unless you see her eat off the same plate as her father.* So Don Mariano had Valentina dressed in white and brought to him at the noon meal, and set one plate between them, and lifted his fork to it once and put it down, and the Judge's men watched it and were satisfied. They brought her to Esperanza, and the Judge married her in the church with the whole county looking on and set her at the head of his house.

III. The Chair

Rancho Santa Rita · 1897

She had a son the next year. When the Judge sent old Pruitt, his foreman, to ask his own mother what the boy ought to be called, the old lady said, *She'd already won every heart in this county before the baby came. Now she'll be his darling past all reason.* But Pruitt had been deaf on one side since a cannon at Glorieta, and he rode back and told the Judge she said to call him Dalton. The Judge supposed it was a name on his mother's side. So the boy was Dalton Rourke. When he was six his father had a little tin star made for him and called him the captain of the county, and everyone laughed, and Dalton wore it on his shirt to Mass.

When he was seven he asked his mother why the other boys got ponies and saddles from their grandfathers at Christmas and nobody ever sent him anything. She told him his grandfather lived a long way off down the river and was a great man and very busy. When he was sixteen he said he was going down to Santa Rita to see his mother's people for himself, and she said no, what would he do there, and he asked again, and again, until she said yes.

She wrote ahead. *I am happy here. I beg my lords to receive my son as they would any of their own.*

The Romeros read the letter in the sala. *We can't embrace that boy as a kinsman,* they said. They sent the younger cousins off to the far pastures, and when Dalton rode in with his father's vaqueros they received him in the sala with every courtesy, and showed him his grandfather and his uncles, and gave him the great carved chair at the head of the room to sit in. He kissed his grandfather's hand and his uncles' hands. Nobody kissed his.

Where are my cousins?

Out with the cattle, hijo. It's the season.

He stayed three days and they could not have treated him better. On the fourth morning he rode out.

Behind him in the sala, one of the kitchen women got down on her knees with a bucket of milk and water and scrubbed the great carved

chair, seat and arms and back. *Look at this,* she said to the girl helping her, *the chair Pilar's grandson sat in.* One of the vaqueros had left his rifle in the corner and come back for it, and he heard her. He asked a question or two in the kitchen. By noon every man riding home with Dalton knew it, and the noise they made about it on the road could be heard a mile off.

Dalton reined in and sat his horse in the road and said it out loud so they would all hear him. *They wash the chair I sat in with milk. When I have this county, I'll wash it with their blood.*

At Esperanza the Judge heard the whole of it from his men before the dust was off them. He was ashamed in front of the county, and for a man like the Judge that was worse than being robbed. He moved Valentina and the boy out of the big house into the rooms behind the kitchen, with the help.

Doña Natividad came to see him a few days after. She agreed with him that the Romeros had done wrong. *They should have given you a daughter of their own house.* Then she said, *But Valentina was married in church as your wife. And that boy has your name. Whose name is a man known by in this county, Judge? His father's or his mother's?* And she told him the old story about the king who found a woman gathering firewood in the hills and married her, and how her son was king after him. The Judge sat a long time. Then he moved them back into the big house.

Dalton did not move back into it in the same way he had moved out. He was sixteen. He took off the tin star that week, and nobody saw it again.

IV. Thirty-Two Sons

Laredo and Esperanza · 1880–1912

SIXTO BENAVIDES'S WIFE AMALIA HAD NO CHILDREN FOR years, and in the end he told her to go back to her family in Laredo. She stopped at the jacal on her way. *Where are you going?* said Doña Natividad. *Home, because I've given him no sons. That's no reason. Go back to your husband.* She went back, and Sixto said, *Why are you here?* and she said, *Doña*

Natividad sent me, and he thought about it and said, *Then she has some reason,* and let it be.

Within the year Amalia was carrying, and she had a craving. In Laredo the rich families kept a bathing tank behind a wall, fed from a spring, with a wire fence over the top of the wall and a man with a shotgun at the gate, and she wanted to go down into it and swim and drink the water. So Sixto drove her to Laredo in his buggy, in by the ferry road past the cane chair where Tomás Leal sat. The blind man heard the wheels and said to the boys around him, *That's Benavides's buggy. There'll be trouble for somebody today.*

Sixto knocked down the man at the gate, pulled down the wire with his hands, and Amalia swam and drank, and he swam too, and they drove home.

The rich young men of Laredo came after them on horseback, fifty or a hundred of them, though the number grew every time it was told. Tomás Leal told them from his chair: *Turn back when you see his wheels sink to the hubs. If you don't, you'll hear a sound like the sky splitting. Turn back then. If you don't, you'll see a hole through every saddle horn. Then you must turn back.* They did not turn back. And this is how it was told on the river for forty years afterward: that Sixto handed Amalia the lines and stood up in the buggy, and the wheels sank to the hubs in the road; that he fired once into the air and it split the sky; and that he fired once more, and the one bullet went through every saddle horn in that company and through every man of them at the belt buckle. They rode on, shouting at him to halt. He stopped the buggy. *You're dead men,* he said. *I don't fight the dead. Have the first of you unbuckle his belt.* The first one unbuckled it and fell off his horse. *Go home,* said Sixto, *settle your affairs, kiss your wives, and then take off your belts.* They did, and that was the end of them.

Amalia gave him twins sixteen times. Thirty-two sons, all of them riders and shots like their father, and when they came into Esperanza behind him on court day the plaza was full of their horses. One court day some men who had been robbed of their land by a crooked judgment came shouting to Sixto in the street. He walked into the courtroom, sat down, and heard the case again himself, and gave the land back to the

men it belonged to, and the plaza cheered him. The Judge was pleased, and put the whole court in his hands.

The old judges lost their bribes, and they took their time. They told the Judge that Benavides wanted the county for himself. The Judge believed them. He could not kill a man the whole plaza had cheered, not in daylight. So he paid some men to make trouble at the river, and sent Sixto and his sons to put it down, and sent other men after them with other orders. The hired raiders ran as soon as they heard who was coming. Sixto made the river quiet again and started home with his boys. A few miles from Esperanza, at the Arroyo Prieto crossing, the other men were waiting in the brush.

That morning Amalia had Doña Natividad and her women at her table, and all their helpers, for a meal she had been planning a month. The telegram came while they were at the soup. She read it and folded it and put it in her apron pocket and went on serving. Then the girl carrying the big olla of lard from the kitchen tripped on the threshold, and the olla went to pieces on the tiles in front of everybody.

Doña Chole, the eldest of the women, said mildly, *Never mind, child. Whatever was made to break is going to break.*

Amalia took the telegram out of her apron. *They brought me this an hour ago. It says my husband is dead and my thirty-two sons with him. I didn't take any notice of that, Doña Chole. I'm not going to take any notice of a pot.*

The women went home. Amalia called her thirty-two daughters-in-law together that night and told them: *Your husbands did nothing wrong. They are paying for something older than they are, that none of us can see. Don't grieve yourselves to death. And don't hate the Judge.* The Judge's men were listening at the window and carried it back to him, and he came the next morning with his hat in his hands and asked her forgiveness and offered her anything she named. She asked for nothing, until after the novena for the dead. Then she asked to be allowed to send the daughters-in-law home to their own people and go home to hers, and he let her, and she went back to Laredo and lived quietly and was never heard to speak his name.

V. The Shade

The river road · September 1915

THE JUDGE MADE SIXTO'S NEPHEW LUCIO HIS CHIEF DEPUTY after that, and Lucio went about the county telling anyone who would listen that the Judge had killed his uncle. The Judge had no peace after Arroyo Prieto. He ate without tasting it. Running the county was no pleasure to him anymore.

In the summer of 1915 there was blood on the river again. Raiders from across the river were firing on trains and cutting the telegraph wires under a plan that said every Anglo man over sixteen in Texas should die, and the Rangers came down from Austin, and men who looked Mexican began to be found dead in the brush. The Judge was eighty years old. Doña Natividad was eighty years old. He drove out to the jacal to see her one evening, and left his car and his pistol and the courthouse keys and the county ledger and the seal with Lucio at the gate, and went in alone, and they sat and talked a long time like two old people.

When he came out the car was gone. Lucio had left him one horse and Cata the cook. She told him: Lucio had driven to the courthouse and handed the keys and the ledger and the seal to Dalton Rourke, and the commissioners, who knew which way the wind was blowing, had made Dalton sheriff before supper. The Judge said he would ride to Brownsville, where his sister's boy had a bank and a hundred friends, and come back and see about it. He rode all night and half the next day in the heat. When he got to Brownsville it was dark, and the bank was shut, and the house was shut, and nobody came to the door. He lay down in a wagon yard by the river with his coat for a pillow and died there in the night. At first light the people at the wagon yard heard Cata crying out, *Judge, Judge, you have nobody now,* and went and told his nephew, who buried him with a band.

Dalton remembered his promise. He rode out of Esperanza at the head of his deputies and a company of Rangers, south for Santa Rita.

That morning Doña Natividad had gone out early on her rounds the way she did, and come home, and lain down through the heat of the day on her right side on her cot, and in the late afternoon, though nobody on the road had seen her pass, she was sitting under a mesquite at the line where the Esperanza road crossed onto Romero land. A mesquite in September gives about as much shade as a fishing net. Twenty steps away, on the Esperanza side of the wire, stood a Texas ebony, black-green and dense, with shade under it like a room.

Dalton rode up and got down. He took his hat off to her. Everyone in the county did that.

Doña Natividad. What are you doing sitting in the sun? Come sit under the ebony, it's cool there.

Don't worry about me, hijo, she said. *The shade of my people keeps me cool.*

He stood there with his hat in his hand. He thought: she's come to stand in front of her kin. He put his hat on and got back on his horse and turned the company around and rode back to Esperanza.

A week later the old hate came up in him again and he rode out a second time, and she was sitting under the same mesquite, and he turned back. He rode out a third time, and she was there, and he turned back.

The fourth time she was not there. She had looked a long while down the river that morning toward Santa Rita, and at the old water tank below the big house that the Romeros never used, which every old woman on that river knew the story of. How in her own great-grandfather's time, when the Lipan bands still came down to water there in the dry months, the Romero men had poisoned that tank one summer, and the people who drank from it had died along its banks. It had been a long time ago. Nobody at Santa Rita spoke of it. But there are debts, she told Chencho, that the land keeps the books on, and she could not sit in the road forever.

She stayed home on her cot with her face to the wall.

VI. Zacate y Carrizo

Rancho Santa Rita · October 1915

The Romeros had a rule older than the ranch, that a Romero did not take a human life, and they were proud of it the way they were proud of everything. But they were the best shots on that river. When they saw the dust of the company coming they put on their cartridge belts and went out among the corrals and the mesquite and opened fire. They shot the hats off the Rangers' heads. They shot the horns off saddles and the heels off boots. They put bullets between men's arms and their ribs, and through the brims of their hats, and past their ears close enough to burn.

Dalton turned in his saddle, looking around. *I was always told the Romeros didn't kill. They're killing my men.*

Sheriff, said the Ranger sergeant beside him, *nobody's dead. Count them.*

He had them counted. Not one man was so much as scratched.

Then he gave his order. *Anybody who says he's a Romero, kill him. Anybody who's standing with Don Mariano, leave him alone.*

The Romeros had run out of ways to hold the Rangers off without killing anybody, and they would not do that. And they had one rule older than the other one, which was that a Romero did not lie. So as the Rangers came through the corrals asking each man, *Romero? Are you a Romero?* some of them pulled up a stalk of grass and put it in their teeth, and when the question came they took it out and held it up and said, *Zacate.* Grass. And some of them snapped off a piece of the river cane that grew along the tank and held it in their hands, and said, *Carrizo.* Cane. The Rangers took it for their names and went on past them. To this day on that river there are families called Zacate and families called Carrizo who will tell you, if you ask them right, that their name is a stalk of grass held up in front of a gun.

Those who stood with Don Mariano in the sala lived. Everyone else at Santa Rita that day who answered to the name of Romero died, the men and the boys, and the old men, and not only the men. The Rangers left

the bodies where they fell, the way some of them were doing that autumn along the river, so the brush would know.

Dalton had the great carved chair carried out of the sala into the yard. What he did with it there, the women who came afterward to wash the dead never said, and nobody ever asked them.

VII. The River

The same day

He took his grandfather with him when he rode out. Don Mariano was ninety and rode straight. At noon they stopped at the river below Santa Rita and the cook got a fire going, and Dalton had a table and two chairs set up in the shade of the cane and a plate brought.

I'll eat with my grandfather, he said. *Sit down, abuelo.*

Don Mariano had sat at one plate with Pilar's daughter once, for the length of one lifted fork, and he had lived thirty-six years since then on the strength of never doing it again. He looked at the plate and at the river.

Grandson, I'm filthy from the road. Let me wash first.

Go and wash, abuelo.

He thought: if I don't sit, he'll shoot me, and if I sit, I've sat. Better to go by my own hand. So he went down to the water through the cane, and took off his boots, and tied his long white hair round his ankles with the cord from his hat, and threw himself into the river.

The vaqueros of that river will tell you what happened next, and so will their grandchildren. A water snake as long as a wagon tongue came up from the bottom of the Rio Grande where the current runs green, and took the old man up on its back, and carried him across to the Mexican side and down into the deep water under the bank, and there he lived twelve years among the river people before anybody saw him again. Some say he came out at last at Camargo, dry as a bone. Some say he never came out.

Dalton sat at the table. *Now my grandfather is coming,* he thought. *Now my grandfather is coming.* The food went cold. At last he had the cane

searched, and the bank, and when it got dark he had the river searched with lanterns, and then he had his own men turn out their saddlebags and the pockets of their coats, as if an old man could hide in a coat. He could not find him anywhere. *He's gone, then,* he said, and they rode on.

VIII. The Arroyo

Arroyo Prieto · that night

They came to Arroyo Prieto after dark and made camp. It had not rained in that country in two months. The arroyo bed was a road of white sand, smooth and soft and still warm from the day, and some of the men spread their blankets down there. Others threw their saddles down on the hard ground of the banks above. Among the ones who went down into the sand were the few who had held back at Santa Rita, who had kept their rifles on their saddles and said nothing and been cursed for it. Most of the ones who had not held back lay on the banks.

Then the red ants came up out of the ground. Big red harvesters, the kind whose bite feels like a coal, boiling up out of their beds wherever a man had lain down, on the banks and in the sand alike. Men leaped up all over the camp in the dark, cursing and slapping. *Ants! Ants, God damn it!* And they changed places. The ones in the sand climbed up onto the banks, and the ones on the banks went down into the sand, Dalton with them, and spread their blankets again, and slept.

Far up the country to the north, where nobody in that camp could see it, a storm that had come in off the Gulf was standing over the hills and raining as if it would never stop.

The water came down Arroyo Prieto a little after two in the morning. The men on the banks said afterward that they heard it before they saw it, a sound like a freight train in a cut, and then a wall of brown water as high as a man on horseback with whole mesquite trees turning in it. It filled the arroyo from bank to bank in less time than it takes to tell it. It took the men in the sand and their blankets and their horses and their rifles and Dalton Rourke and carried them down into the Rio Grande, and the Rio Grande carried them down to the Gulf of Mexico, and they

were food for the fish and the turtles. A few saddles turned up on sandbars below Brownsville, weeks later. Nothing else.

• • •

All that winter on the river people talked about it in low voices. It wasn't right, some said, what was done to the Romeros, no matter what. And the women said the Romeros had their own old debts, and the land keeps the books. And the men said that Dalton had got just what he had coming, and had not lived to enjoy one day of what he had wanted all his life.

Doña Natividad heard them talking on her gallery one evening, the women who came to learn from her, and asked them what it was. They told her. She sat a while with her hands in her lap. Then she said it to them, the Gospel they had heard read at Mass all their lives, and they heard it as if for the first time.

> *For as in the days before the flood, they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, even till that day in which Noe entered into the ark, And they knew not till the flood came, and took them all away; so also shall the coming of the Son of man be.*
>
> *— Matthew 24:38–39*

He wanted it so badly, she said. *He was so busy wanting it. They all were.*

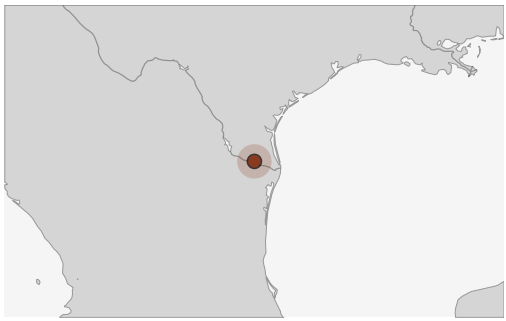
She sent Chencho out the next morning to cut cane by the river. When he came back she sat on the gallery and split it and wove it, the way she had as a girl at Santa Rita, into a new seat for an old chair whose seat had rotted through, and when it was done she set the chair out under the mesquite by the road, in the thin shade, where anybody who was tired could sit down.

Background

The verse

> *Death carries off a man who is gathering flowers and whose mind is distracted, as a flood carries off a sleeping village.*
>
> Dhammapada 47, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary tells how King Pasenadi of Kosala, wanting the trust of the Buddha's monks, asks the Buddha's own clan, the proud Sākyans, for a bride. They send him the daughter of a Sākyan noble and a slave woman, and the noble pretends to eat from one dish with her. Her son Viḍūḍabha, visiting his mother's kin at sixteen, learns the truth when a slave washes the seat he sat on with milk and water, and vows to wash it in their blood. Woven through are the stories of Pasenadi's schoolfriends, the blind teacher Mahāli and the general Bandhula, whom Pasenadi has murdered with his thirty-two sons, and of Bandhula's widow Mallikā, who goes on serving the monks after reading the news. When Pasenadi is deposed and dies outside a shut city gate, Viḍūḍabha marches on the Sākyans. Three times the Buddha sits in his path in the thin shade of a tree; the fourth time he does not, knowing the Sākyans once poisoned a river. The Sākyans, who will neither kill nor lie, are massacred, except some who hold up grass or reeds, and the Sākyan Mahānāma, who drowns himself rather than eat with his grandson and is carried off by a serpent king. That night ants drive the army down into a dry riverbed, and a flood carries them all to the sea. Read the full commentary story, or about Viḍūḍabha and Pasenadi.



The Rio Grande border, Texas

The Rio Grande border, 1915

In January 1915 a manifesto called the Plan of San Diego called for an uprising in South Texas and the killing of white men over sixteen. Raids began that summer and peaked in August and September, with attacks on ranches and trains and telegraph

lines, and about twenty-one Americans were killed. The reprisals were far worse. Texas Rangers, local lawmen and vigilantes killed Mexican Americans and Mexicans across the border country, sometimes leaving the bodies where they fell as a warning. Estimates of the dead in the decade run from three hundred to five thousand. Mexicans called the Rangers *los diablos tejanos*, and the years are remembered as La Matanza, the massacre; in 1919 State Representative José Tomás Canales brought about a legislative investigation of the Rangers.

Many Tejano families on the river traced their land to the porciones that a Spanish royal commission began surveying in 1767 at Laredo, Mier, Camargo, Revilla and Reynosa. Healers like Doña Natividad were part of daily life in the region; the most famous, Don Pedrito Jaramillo, "the healer of Los Olmos Creek," treated thousands until his death in 1907 (see curanderismo). Esperanza, Rancho Santa Rita, Arroyo Prieto and every character here are invented, and so are the massacre at Santa Rita and the flood; no Ranger company was ever lost that way. The violence they stand for was real.

After the story of Viḍūḍabha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 47). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

4.4

Since Morning

> *Let us crown ourselves with roses, before they be withered.*
> *— Wisdom 2:8*

The way I heard it, on Kanaka Creek.

I. The Tree

Kanaka Creek, on the Fraser River · spring 1874

Peter Kauwila's girl did not talk until she was nearly three, and then one evening in the kitchen she said a whole thing at once, as if she had been saving it.

I was up in the tree throwing flowers down for my husband, she said, *and then I was here.*

Her mother was a Kwantlen woman from up the river, and she was cleaning a pail of eulachon at the table, and she stopped. Peter laughed. He had been laughing at that child since the day she came, because she had come in the middle of May with the wild roses out on every bank down to the water, and he had named her Lokelani, which is a rose in the language he still dreamed in, and the Oblate father from St. Mary's had written it down as Rosalie.

What tree? he said.

She could not say what tree. A big one, in a garden, with flowers on it all the way up, and a great many girls in it, more than she could count, some up in the branches throwing and some down on the grass picking up what fell and fastening it on him. On the man. Her husband. He was sitting in the middle and they were dressing him in flowers.

Peter had come out to Fort Vancouver on a Company ship in 1845 and had not seen O'ahu since. He knew what she was describing, or thought

he did. He told her about the women on the wharf at Honolulu with yellow ilima strung so thick you could not see the thread, and the maile vine that smelled sweet for a week after it was cut, and the men going down to the boats with their necks hung so heavy with flowers they had to lift their chins. *That is where you were,* he said. *Before you were born. You were over there watching for me.* He was pleased with this and told it at the next feast, when they had a pig in the ground at the mouth of the creek under skunk cabbage leaves and sacking, and everybody agreed that the girl had the islands in her though she had never been nearer to them than Victoria.

Only old Ka'ai did not laugh. He was sitting on an upturned box by the pit, eating salmon off a cedar stick with his fingers, already grey. He had come to the river in 1830, a boy of fourteen, and had dug potatoes and rolled fur bales and buried other Hawaiians at Fort Vancouver and Fort Langley for nearly thirty years, and when the Company let its Hawaiians go in 1858 he had crossed the Fraser with the others and cleared ground by the creek to grow apples. He wiped his hands on his trousers and called the child over and looked at her a while.

In that garden, he said. *Was it morning?*

Morning, she said, very sure.

He nodded as if that settled something, and gave her a clam, and that was all he said about it. She did not say it again, not to anyone. By the time she was six she had either forgotten it or had learned which things people laugh at.

II. Henry's Rosie

Kanaka Creek · 1884–1901

BUT SHE MADE GARLANDS. EVERY CHILD ON THE CREEK COULD string a lei, because their fathers were homesick and showed them how, but Rosalie strung them the way other girls breathe. Nootka rose in May and June, the little pink single ones that drop their petals if you look at them, so she picked them in bud at dawn and strung them wet. Ocean spray in July, the creamy heads that look like foam on the bank. Honey-

SUCKLE OFF THE FENCES, AND WILD SYRINGA. IN AUGUST pearly everlasting, which dried on the stem and kept its shape all winter. In winter, when there was nothing, cedar tips and salal and the red berries of the kinnikinnick. She hung them on the posts of the porch, on the cow, on her small brothers, and when the chapel was finished at the mouth of the creek she began to hang them there.

It was a plank chapel, not much bigger than a smokehouse, and they called it St. Paul's. The Hawaiian men had built it with their Kwantlen in-laws out of cedar they split themselves, on a rise above the high-water line where the creek came into the Fraser, so that it stood looking across the river at Derby, where the old fort had been. A bell came up from New Westminster on the sternwheeler one year and the whole creek walked down to hear it rung. There was no priest nearer than the Oblates at St. Mary's upriver. Father came down when the river and his rounds let him, perhaps once a month in summer, less in winter, in a canoe or on the boat with his bag on his knees. On the other Sundays the people came anyway, and old Ka'ai led the rosary in the front pew in a voice like a bucket being let down a well.

Somebody had to keep the place. Nobody asked Rosalie to. She simply began, at thirteen, walking down from her father's place on Saturday with a broom over her shoulder, and after a while it was hers. She swept out the fir needles and the dried mud and the mice. She filled the bucket at the creek and set it inside the door with the tin dipper on a nail above it, because people walked four and five miles to Mass or paddled down from Whonnock and across from Derby and came in thirsty. She set out the benches for the overflow. She wiped the two glass windows, which had cost more than the rest of the chapel together. She hung a garland on the statue of St. Paul, who was holding his sword and his book, and on the feast of St. Peter and St. Paul at the end of June she hung so many roses in the church that the women said you could smell it from the river.

When Father came, it was Rosalie who fed him. The families sent things up to the church with their children. Smoked salmon, eggs in a pail, a loaf, a sack of apples, a jar of blackberry jam. *Give this to Rosalie for Father,* they said, because it was easier, and she would carry it all to the

little room behind the altar and set it out on a clean flour sack. She kept the list of whose turn it was to give him a bed. She knew which families wanted a baby baptized and which wanted a marriage blessed that had already been a marriage for three years, and she told him quietly, in the doorway, before he went out to them, so nobody would have to say it aloud.

And every time, putting down the eggs or the salmon or setting the dipper on its nail, she said the same few words under her breath. Some of the girls heard her and repeated it.

Let this help me get back to my husband.

She was married by then. She married at sixteen, in St. Paul's, to Henry Naone from down the river, whose father had been a Company man like hers and whose mother was Katzie. Henry was a sealer. Every January he went down to Victoria on the boat and signed on one of the schooners that crowded the inner harbour, seventy or eighty of them some years, and was gone down the coast after the herd, and in the summer up to the Bering Sea, and home in the fall smelling of oil and smoke with his money sewn into his coat. In 1888 he came home and there was a son. In 1890 there was another, in 1893 a third, in 1896 the fourth, and Henry was away at the birth of every one.

So of course they understood her. All summer long, while Henry was off the Pribilofs in fog, she was in the church with her broom and her bucket and her four boys trailing after her, and every time she put something down she prayed to get back to her husband. The women thought it was the sweetest thing on the river. The men teased Henry about it at the Haney landing. They called her Henry's Rosie, and then just Henry's, as in *ask Henry's*, *give it to Henry's for Father*, and she answered to it without minding, and never once corrected anybody.

The only one who never called her that was old Ka'ai. He called her *keiki*, child, until she was a grown woman with four boys of her own, and once when she was hanging a garland on St. Paul he stopped behind her on his two sticks and said, *Still morning?* and she laughed and said, *Uncle, I don't know what you mean,* and went red to the ears.

III. The Lamp

A Sunday in August 1901

Father came over on the Saturday that month, a young Fleming named Father Cyriel who had been in the country two years and still blessed himself every time the boat heeled. Rosalie had been up since four. She had walked to the church in the dark with the two older boys carrying the benches between them, and swept, and filled the bucket at the creek, and set the dipper on its nail. She had hung St. Paul with pearly everlasting and the last of the fireweed. At Mass she knelt at the end of the second pew with the four boys in a row beside her, the youngest asleep against her arm, and she went up to the rail and received, and came back, and listened to the whole of the sermon, which was in an English the young priest was still building as he went along, and was about the ten virgins and their lamps.

Afterward she fed him at the table behind the altar. Salmon, new potatoes, a plate of blackberries, coffee. Three families had sent food that day and she had set it all out and named each family to him as he ate, so he would know whom to thank. Then she washed the plates in the bucket and swept again where the boys had tracked in the dust, and walked home with them along the shore in the long light, with the youngest on her hip.

At home she milked. She put the boys to bed. She sat down at the kitchen table to fill the lamps, which was the last thing every night, and she was pouring the coal oil from the can into the second lamp when she put her hand to the side of her head behind the eye and said to her eldest boy, who was thirteen and still awake, *Joe, go and get your grandmother.*

By the time he came back with his grandmother she was on the floor beside the table. She was dead before the moon came up over Derby. The coal oil had run across the boards and the lamp she had lit to see by was still burning on the table, and her mother turned it down, and it went out.

• • •

What happened next is what old Kaʻai said happened, and on Kanaka Creek nobody ever argued with him.

In the garden it was still morning. The girls in the branches were throwing down flowers, the girls on the grass were fastening them on the man in the middle, and the light had not moved. She was in her tree again, on the same branch, with her lap full of blossoms. She threw them down. He looked up.

We haven't seen you since this morning, he said. *Where did you go?*

I died, husband. I went out of here.

What are you saying?

It's true.

Where did you go?

To a river. Way off. I was born to a man from the islands and a woman from the river, in a family that was all right.

And how long were you there?

She told him. Nine months and then born. Sixteen years and married. Four boys. A church to keep, a bucket and a broom, a garland on a saint every feast day, and every time she set a thing down, a prayer to get back to him.

How long do they live there, the people?

A hundred years, if they're lucky. Mostly less.

That's all?

That's all.

He was quiet a while, with the flowers still falling on him.

With so little time, he said, *what do they do with it? Do they sleep it away? Or do they give and work and look after each other?*

Husband, they live as if they had a thousand years. As if they would never get old. As if it would never come for them.

The man in the garden was troubled by this as he had not been troubled by anything, because for him not one day had passed since she fell out of the tree. It had not been an hour. A hundred of our years, old Kaʻai said, is one day and one night in that garden, and the people there live a thousand of their years, and if you want to know what that comes to

you had better ask the schoolteacher at Haney, because he could not do the arithmetic and did not need to.

If they have so little, said the man in the garden, *and spend it asleep, when do they ever get out?*

IV. The Dipper

St. Paul's chapel · Monday

Father Cyriel had stayed the night on the creek so he could say a Mass on the Monday morning for the people who had come too late on the Sunday, and he walked up to the church at seven with three or four of the men. The door was shut. Inside, the benches were stacked against the wall where the boys had left them, and the floor had the boys' tracks on it, and the bucket by the door was empty and dry, with the dipper hanging over it on its nail.

He stood and looked at it. In two years he had never once come into that church and found the bucket empty.

Where is Henry's? he said, the way everyone said it.

One of the men had already heard. He took off his hat. *Father, you won't see her. Last night, after you ate and she went home, she died.*

The young priest sat down on the end of a bench. He had eaten her salmon not eighteen hours before and she had told him which family had caught it. He put his face in his hands and wept the way a young man does when he has not yet buried many people he knew, and the men stood around him not knowing where to look. Two of them wept as well. The older ones did not. They stood very still, the way you stand on a schooner deck when the glass has dropped and nobody has said so yet.

Old Kaʻai had come up behind them on his two sticks. He did not weep either. He took the bucket off the floor and went out with it, and they heard him going down to the creek, very slowly, and coming back. He set it inside the door and hung the dipper over it. Then he took the broom from the corner and began to sweep.

They said the rosary for her on Monday night, in her mother's house, with Rosalie laid out on the table where she had been filling the lamps.

Ka'ai led it. Afterward, when the women had gone out to the kitchen and the boys were asleep in a heap on the bed, the priest and the men sat on with him by the body, and it was the priest who asked, because he was young enough to.

She was so busy all her life, he said. *She did every good work there was, and she only wanted to be with her husband. Now she's dead. Where is she?*

With her husband, said Ka'ai.

Henry's in the Bering Sea. He doesn't even know.

Not that husband.

The men looked at each other. Ka'ai shifted on his chair and told it to them then, all of it, the tree and the garden and the girls and the man sitting in the middle being dressed in flowers, the way a child of three had told it in that same kitchen twenty-seven years before, and what she had asked him every time she set a thing down, and where she had gone back to on Sunday night after she filled the first lamp and before she could fill the second.

Uncle, said one of the men. *Is that true?*

It's true.

Father Cyriel did not say it was not. He sat with his breviary shut on his knee and his thumb in it, looking at the woman on the table, and after a while he said, half to himself, a line out of the psalms he said every week in his breviary, as though it had just been explained to him.

> *For a thousand years in thy sight are as yesterday, which is past. And as a watch in the night.*
>
> *— Psalm 89:4 (Douay-Rheims)*

She gave you breakfast, said one of the men, to the priest, as if he could not get over it. *She gave you your dinner yesterday, and last night she was gone. How short is that?*

Short, said Ka'ai. *All of it is short. And everybody here goes on like they had a thousand years in the bank. Reaching for one more thing. One more boat, one more season, one more flower. It comes and takes them with their hands still full, and they cry the whole way.*

That was a long speech for him, and he looked tired after it. The priest put the breviary away and took out the little Douay Bible he carried in his coat, and turned in it a while by the lamp, and found the place, and read it out to the men in his careful built English, the words of the people who say life is short and so let us have all of it.

> *Come therefore, and let us enjoy the good things that are present, and let us speedily use the creatures as in youth. Let us fill ourselves with costly wine, and ointments: and let not the flower of the time pass by us. Let us crown ourselves with roses, before they be withered: let no meadow escape our riot.*
>
> *— Wisdom 2:6–8*

Nobody said anything. Outside the river went by in the dark with the small sound it makes along the bank. One of the men, a sealer who had shipped with Henry on three different schooners, got up and went to the door and stood looking at the river for a long time with his hat in his hands, and when he came back in he said he would not go up north next year, and he did not go.

V. Rose Hips

Kanaka Creek · October 1901

They buried her on the Wednesday in the ground beside the church, among the Hawaiians and their Kwantlen wives and the babies, and Father Cyriel read over her the place in Wisdom about the just man taken young.

> *Being made perfect in a short space, he fulfilled a long time.*
>
> *— Wisdom 4:13*

Henry came home in the middle of October. The schooner had put into Victoria on the ninth, and he had heard it on the wharf there from a man off another boat, and come up the river on the sternwheeler with his money still sewn in his coat. He walked from the landing to the church

before he went to his own house, and found the bucket full inside the door and the floor swept. Ka'ai had done it every Saturday since. The old man could carry the bucket only half full now and had to rest twice on the way up from the creek, but it was done.

Henry did not go into the church. He went around to the side, to the new grave, where his eldest boy Joe was kneeling in the wet grass. It was too late in the year for any flowers. The roses on the banks along the river had gone to hips weeks before, hard and red and shining, and Joe had picked a hat full and was stringing them on a length of his mother's thread with her needle, the way she had shown all four of them, pushing the needle through each one and sliding it down. It was slow work. The hips were tough and the needle kept sticking. When the string was long enough he tied it in a ring and laid it on the turned earth below the cross, and it lay there in the rain, very red.

In the garden it was not yet noon. The man in the middle sat with his chin lifted under the weight of the flowers, and he had not said a word since she told him about the river. The girls on the grass were still fastening on him the roses she had thrown down from her branch that morning, before she fell.

Background

The verse

> *Death subdues a man who is gathering flowers, and whose mind is distracted, before he is satiated in his pleasures.*
>
> Dhammapada 48, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a goddess of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three is up a tree in a pleasure garden, throwing down flowers to deck her husband, the god Mālābhārī ("Garland-Wearer"), when she dies out of that world like a lamp flame and is born a girl in Sāvatthī, remembering him. She grows up, marries at sixteen, bears four sons, keeps the monks' hall, sets out water and seats, and with every offering prays to be reborn with her husband, so the monks call her Patipūjikā, "Husband-Honorer," assuming she means the husband she has. One day she gives alms, hears the teaching, keeps the precepts, and dies that evening. In heaven no time has passed, for a hun-

dred human years are one day and night there, and her divine husband is shaken to hear how short and careless human lives are. The next morning the monks find the hall untended and weep; the Buddha tells them she has gone back to her true husband, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.

Kanaka Creek, British Columbia

Kanaka Creek and the Fraser, 1858–1901

Hawaiian men, called Kanakas, worked for the Hudson's Bay Company all over the Pacific Northwest in the first half of the nineteenth century, and many married First Nations women and stayed (Kanaka workers). Hawaiians were among the crew that came up from Fort Vancouver in 1827 to build Fort Langley on the Fraser. After the Company lost its trading monopoly in 1858 and the townsite of Derby was laid out at the old fort, a number of its Hawaiian employees crossed the river with their Kwantlen wives and took up land along a stream that came to be called Kanaka Creek, in what is now Maple Ridge. They farmed and fished; the community was always small (the 1881 census counted nineteen people of Hawaiian descent there) and lasted thirty or forty years, the last house gone by 1912 (Maple Ridge Museum). The nearest priests were the Oblates of St. Mary's Mission upriver, founded in 1861; the chapel in the story is invented.

From the 1880s the Victoria fleet of pelagic sealing schooners, at its height over a hundred vessels, followed the northern fur seal herd from the coast up to the Bering Sea and the Pribilof Islands, carrying Indigenous hunters in canoes and mixed crews of every origin. The hunt ended with the North Pacific Fur Seal Convention of 1911.

After the story of Patipūjikā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 48). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

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Seven Doors

> *The bee is small among flying things but her fruit hath the chiefest sweetness.*
> *— Ecclesiasticus 11:3*

Así lo platican, on Highway 35.

I. The Tayuyo

Ribbon Cane, Mississippi · Thursday, August 8, 2019

Efraín Maldonado had come to Mississippi in 1996 on a bus the chicken company sent to Texas, and for four years he hung live birds by their feet on a moving line in the dark. Then he saw where the money was. The money was in everything around the chicken. He bought a van and charged eight dollars a day to ride in it. He bought a trailer and rented the beds in it by the shift. He cashed paychecks for three cents on the dollar and wired what was left to Guatemala for a fee. By 2019 he owned the old dime store on what remained of the main street in Ribbon Cane, a two-story brick building with a tienda downstairs and his family upstairs, and nine trailers on a lot behind the feed mill, and four vans, and people said he had a million dollars, and nobody had ever seen him give away a lime.

He did not spend it on himself either. He wore the boots he had bought in 2004. His wife Marta cooked on a stove with two working burners. His money was like one of those stock ponds out in the pines with a cottonmouth living in it. The water is right there and nothing goes down to drink.

On the Wednesday, the government came to seven chicken plants in six towns with buses and zip ties and took six hundred and eighty people

off the lines. It was the first day of school. By Thursday half the trailers in Scott County had nobody in them to pay the rent, and Efraín drove the sixty miles up Highway 35 to see the personnel man at the plant about who was going to be working and who was not. The personnel man kept him waiting two hours and told him nothing.

He stopped for gas on the way home. On the curb by the ice machine sat a boy of sixteen or so in a plant sweatshirt, thin as a hoe handle, new enough from the mountains that he still looked at the ground when a truck went by. He had a bread bag in his lap, and out of it he took a tayuyo and began to eat.

A tayuyo is the plainest thing a person from those mountains can eat. It is a thick corn cake, round, the size of a saucer, with a spoonful of black beans patted into the middle before it goes on the comal. This one was a day old and cold. The boy ate it with both hands, slowly, and a little of the beans showed dark at the edge where he had bitten.

Efraín had not eaten a tayuyo in twenty years. Marta made tortillas from the bag like everybody. He stood with the gas nozzle in his hand, and his mouth filled with water like a dog's, and he was hungrier than he had been since he was a child.

He drove home with it. He thought: *If I say I want tayuyos, she will make them. If she makes them the girls from the store will smell it, and the nephews, and the drivers, and every one of them will want one, and then it is five pounds of masa and a pot of beans and lard and gas for the stove, and this week of all weeks, with the whole county looking for somewhere to eat.* So he said nothing. He walked around the store all afternoon straightening cans. By evening he was the color of old tallow and the veins stood out in his neck, and he went upstairs and lay down on the bed with his face to the wall and his arms around the pillow.

Marta came and sat by him and rubbed his back.

What is it, viejo?

Nothing.

Did the man at the plant say something to you?

He said nothing to me.

Is it the kids? Did one of the drivers wreck a van?

Nobody wrecked anything.

Then you want something.

He did not answer. She waited. She had been married to him for thirty-one years.

Tell me what you want, Efraín.

He said it into the pillow, swallowing half of it. *A tayuyo.*

A tayuyo! Why didn't you say? Are we poor? I'll make enough for all of Ribbon Cane. God knows they need it this week.

What are they to you? Let them work and buy their own.

Then enough for the people in our trailers.

I always said you had a hole in your hand.

Then for this house. The girls downstairs, the nephews.

You'd feed the cat first.

Then for you and me and the children.

What do the children need with tayuyos? They eat pizza.

For you and me, then.

What do you want one for?

Marta looked at the back of his head for a moment.

All right, she said. *Just for you.*

Then he rolled over. *Not in the kitchen. There are too many noses in this building. Take the hot plate and the small comal up to the back storeroom, tomorrow, when the store is busy. Use the masa from the sack that tore, the one I couldn't sell. Use the beans from Sunday. A little lard. Bring the cream and the cheese and that jar of honey the Lopez woman paid with, but only a little of each. I'll come up and eat it by myself.*

All right, said Marta.

II. Seven Doors

Friday morning

THE BACK STOREROOM WAS AT THE TOP OF THE BUILDING, UNder the roof, behind everything. To get there from the street a person went through the steel grille and then the glass door with the bell on it. Then there was the gate in the counter, and the stockroom door, and the

DOOR TO THE STAIRS. AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS WAS THE door of the apartment, and at the end of the hall the storeroom door itself, which had a hasp. That made seven.

Marta went up first with the hot plate. At ten o'clock Efraín told the girls he had accounts to do and followed her, and he shut every door behind him. He turned the key in the ones that had keys and shot the bolt on the ones that had bolts. He hung the padlock in the hasp from the inside, where no hasp was ever meant to be locked from, and sat down on a case of lamp oil with his knees together.

The room had one window, over the alley, two stories up, painted shut. There was a smoke detector on the ceiling with its cover hanging open. He had taken the battery out in 2011 to use in a flashlight.

Marta set the comal on the hot plate and wet her hands and began to pat out the masa.

• • •

Sixty miles north, off the same highway, there was a metal building that had been a tractor dealership and was now a mission church. Since Wednesday night it had also been a kitchen and a law office and a place to sleep. There were five hundred people in it that Friday, more or less. Some had come out of the buses with a paper and a court date. Some were waiting on a husband or a wife who was in Louisiana by now. A good many had papers and had done nothing, and were afraid to be seen driving.

The one who held it together was Catarina Tomás. She was twenty-nine. She had cut wings on the debone line for eleven years, and on Sundays when the priest was at one of his other three churches she led the Celebration of the Word, in Spanish and then in Mam, from a folding table. She had been taken on Wednesday with her knife apron still on. They let her go at one in the morning because she had two children in the second and fourth grades. Before she went they locked a black box the size of a deck of cards around her ankle, and with it they gave her a paper with a line drawn around where she was permitted to be.

The box had to be charged two hours a day, on her leg, from the wall. So on Friday morning she was sitting on a folding chair beside the outlet in the corner of the hall with the cord running up under her skirt, and the hall went on around her, and people who needed to know something came to the chair.

The old man who kept the keys of the mission was named Lorenzo Pérez. He was sixty-eight, from the same mountain she was, and had been sacristan in his village until 1982, when it stopped being safe to be one. He had his papers. He drove the church van. He had a way of coming into a room so that you only noticed afterward that he was in it. People called him Tat Lencho, which is how you say it in Mam to a man of that age.

Catarina looked up from the chair. She had been looking at the floor, at nothing, the way she did.

Tat Lencho. Down in Ribbon Cane, Efraín Maldonado wanted a tayuyo yesterday and was afraid somebody would see him eat it. Right now his wife is making them for him on a hot plate at the top of the store, and he has locked seven doors. Go down there. Bring him to himself. Then bring him and Doña Marta here, and the tayuyos, and the cream and the cheese and the honey. The people in this building are going to eat today off that comal.

Yes, hermana, said Tat Lencho, and put on his hat.

III. The Window

Ribbon Cane · the same minute

Efraín looked up from the comal and there was a man standing outside the window.

The window was twenty feet above the alley. There was no ledge under it and no ladder. The old man stood out there in the open air about a yard from the glass, in a clean white shirt buttoned to the neck, with his hat in his hands, and looked in with the mild face of somebody waiting to be noticed at a counter.

Efraín's heart went like a fish on a bank. He knew the old man. Everybody did. *This is what I locked the doors against,* he thought, *and he comes to the one place there is no door.*

He was a man whose anger went off like salt thrown on a fire. He put his face to the glass and shouted through it.

What do you think you'll get, standing in the air? You can walk up and down out there till you wear a path, you'll get nothing from me.

Tat Lencho put his hat on, and walked up and down, the length of the building and back, over the alley and the dumpster.

What do you think you'll get by walking? You can sit down out there with your legs crossed, you'll get nothing.

The old man folded his legs under him and sat down on the air, a little stiffly, as he sat on the floor of the mission with the children.

What do you get by sitting? Come stand on my windowsill if you like. Nothing.

Tat Lencho got up and came and stood on the outside sill, with the toes of his boots against the glass.

Stand there, then! Stand there till you smoke! You'll get nothing!

Smoke began to come out of the old man. It came from his cuffs and his collar and from under the brim of his hat, gray and thick, with the smell of pine kindling. It came in around the painted window frame and through the wall, until the storeroom was full of it and Marta was coughing over the comal. Efraín's eyes felt as if somebody were putting needles in them. He looked up at the smoke detector hanging open and empty on the ceiling, and he thought about a brick building with a tienda full of lamp oil on the ground floor. He had been about to say: *burst into flames, then.* He did not say it.

He isn't going to leave, he said to Marta. *Make one small one. A little one. Give it to him and get him off my wall.*

Marta pinched off a piece of masa the size of a walnut and patted it flat and put it on the comal. It spread. It rose. It grew out to the rim of the comal and over it, thick as a hand, and lay there steaming, big enough for a family.

You took too much, said Efraín. *Give me that.* He took a spoon and lifted on the tip of it a bit of masa no bigger than a bean and dropped it on the iron himself. It came up bigger than hers.

He tried again, with less. Marta tried. Each one they made was bigger than the last, and the basket filled, and the sack that had torn did not seem to be getting any lower.

Enough, he said. He was sweating. *Give him one out of the basket. One.*

Marta reached into the cloth and took hold of the top one, and the whole basketful came up with it. They had grown together at the edges like biscuits in a pan.

They're stuck, Efraín.

Give it here. He could not part them either. He got his thumbs in and could not. So he took one side and she took the other, and the two of them leaned back with their heels braced on the floorboards, sixty years old apiece, and pulled with everything they had, and the tayuyos held.

The sweat ran off him. It ran down his back and into his eyes and dripped from his chin onto his boots from 2004. He stood there with his arms shaking and his shirt stuck to him, breathing. And he found that he did not want one. He looked for the hunger that had put him to bed, and it had gone out of him with the water.

He let go of his side.

I don't need them, he said. *Marta. Give him the basket. Give him all of it.*

She got the window up. Nobody afterward could say how, with the paint on it. Tat Lencho stepped down over the sill into the room, and the smoke went out past him into the morning. He did not take the basket. He stood with his hat in his hands again and spoke to them in their own language, which Efraín had not let anyone speak to him in for twenty years.

He did not say much. He said that what is given does not get lost. That a thing done has a fruit, the good and the bad, whether anybody is keeping the book or not. That there is this side and there is the other side. That a person has a mother and a father and owes them. That there are still people in the world who walk straight, and can tell you what they have seen.

Efraín heard it. It was nothing he had not been told at seven years old. This time it reached him.

Sit down, Tat, he said. *Sit here on the box. Eat.*

Hermana Catarina is waiting to eat these with the people, said Tat Lencho. *If you're willing, let Doña Marta bring the basket and the rest, and we'll go to her.*

Where is she?

At the mission. Sixty miles.

That's an hour and a quarter. They'll be cold. And they have the road blocked at Raleigh, people say.

We'll take your back stairs, the old man said. *The top of them can stay where it is. The bottom will be at her door. You'll be there sooner than you could get down to your own store.*

IV. The Foot of the Stairs

The mission, Scott County · noon

Efraín took the padlock out of the hasp. He carried the cream and the cheese. Marta carried the basket in both arms with the honey jar riding on top, and Tat Lencho went ahead of them down the back stairs, which were steep and dark and smelled of onions. There were fourteen steps. Efraín had counted them every day for fifteen years. At the bottom was the door to the stockroom.

The old man opened it, and the noise of five hundred people came through.

They stepped out onto a concrete floor under fluorescent lights. There were folding tables end to end, and children asleep on coats along the wall, and a woman in a suit from Jackson with a laptop and a line of forty people in front of her. In the corner by the outlet a young woman in a plant sweatshirt sat on a folding chair with a cord running down to her ankle. She looked up at them as if they were on time.

It's the hour to eat, hermana, Efraín heard himself say. He had not planned to say anything.

Catarina unplugged herself, wound the cord around her hand, and came to the head of the first table. People sat down wherever there was a chair, and where there was not they stood.

Marta lifted the top tayuyo out of the basket. It came away by itself, easily, as a tayuyo ought to. She put it in Catarina's two hands. Catarina broke it and ate half, which was what she needed, and gave the other half to the child beside her.

Then Marta went down the tables with the basket, and Efraín went behind her with the cream and the crumbled cheese and the jar of honey and a spoon. He had sold these people phone cards. He had rented beds to most of them. He put cream on their tayuyos one at a time and they said *gracias, Don Efraín* without any surprise, as though this were what he did.

An old woman near the end of the second table looked up when he got to her and kept looking.

You're Tino Maldonado's boy, she said.

Yes, señora.

I thought it was Tino himself with the spoon. I thought, he's dead thirty years and here he is feeding people again. She told the table. *His father carried the fiesta of the patron four times. Four. The grandfather before him, and the one before that. Seven of them back, they say, one after another. You'd sell your mule to do it once. Tino fed the whole town for eight days, and marimba, and he died owing on the mule.*

He died owing on everything, Efraín said. *I was the one they came to for it. I was fourteen.* He stood holding the honey. *I told the elders I would never carry it. I told them I'd sooner leave. So I left.*

Well, the old woman said, and held out her plate. *You have his face on today.*

• • •

Five hundred people ate. The lawyers ate, and the children who had been sleeping, and the two deputies in the parking lot who had been sent to keep an eye on things. Efraín and Marta sat down last and ate as much as

they wanted. He had three. They tasted like six in the morning at his mother's fire.

The basket was full. Marta carried it around again, to the families in the Sunday school rooms and the men who would not come inside. It was full when she came back.

Hermana, she said, *they don't run out.*

Then put them by the gate, Catarina said, *for whoever comes at night and is afraid to knock.*

There was a red clay bank by the gate where the dealership had cut its driveway. They turned the basket out there on clean cardboard, and it made a heap as high as a child. People came in the night. To this day the ones who were there that week call that bank *el cerro de los tayuyos*, Tayuyo Hill, and their children call it that without knowing why.

Before the two of them went back, Catarina thanked them. She did it standing, in front of everyone, in three or four sentences. She did not flatter him. She said the food had been good and the people had been hungry, and that today the one who gave and the ones who ate had been fed off the same comal. Efraín stood with his hat in his hands. Something that had been shut in him since he was fourteen came open, quietly, and Marta beside him felt the same thing at the same moment and took hold of his sleeve.

They went back through the door in the wall, and up fourteen steps, and they were in their own hall with the smell of smoke still in it.

He took the grille off the front of the store that afternoon and never put it back. He forgave August in all nine trailers, and then September. The vans ran to the courthouse in Jackson and the detention center in Louisiana for the price of the gas, and after a while for nothing. He paid bonds. It went on for years, and he did it without speeches, as a man pays down a note. When he had nothing left that was worth locking up, he put the battery back in the smoke detector.

V. The Bee

The mission · Saturday evening

THE NEXT NIGHT, WHEN THE DISHES WERE DONE, THE PEOPLE who had been there sat on the folding chairs and talked about it. Mostly they talked about Tat Lencho.

Efraín Maldonado, they said. *Of all people. And he never shamed him. He never asked him for a cent. He stood there with his hat in his hands, and the man still has his store and his name and his wife looking at him like a bride. He lost nothing by it. We have had preachers through here who could empty a house in a week, and the family hated God afterward.*

Tat Lencho was not there to hear it. He was out by the gate picking up paper plates.

Catarina was in her corner with the cord in the wall. She had with her the one thing she owned that had come over the mountain, a small book with the cover gone, soft as cloth. It had been her grandfather's. A Spanish priest had given it to him in 1975, when he was made a catechist. He had kept it buried in a lard tin through the bad years, and it still smelled a little of the lard. It was the book the bishop of Geneva wrote four hundred years ago for people who have to live in the world and work.

What are you talking about? she asked.

They told her.

That is how it should be done, she said. *Whoever goes into a house for God should go in like that. The house ought to be better for it and no poorer.* She opened the book to a page near the front where the paper had gone brown from a thumb. *My grandfather had this by heart. He said it was the whole of his trade.*

> *Aristotle says that the bee sucks honey from flowers without damaging them, leaving them as whole and fresh as it found them;—but true devotion does better still, for it not only hinders no manner of vocation or duty, but, contrariwise, it adorns and beautifies all.*
>
> *— St. Francis de Sales, Introduction to the Devout Life, I.3*

That's Tat Lencho, she said. *And the other one you know already.*

> *The bee is small among flying things but her fruit hath the chiefest sweetness.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 11:3*

She closed the book and bent to look at the light on her ankle, which had gone from red to green.

Out at the gate the sun was almost down. The kudzu had come over the top of the clay bank that summer and was in bloom, as it is in August, purple, with a smell like grape soda. The old man stood with a trash bag in one hand and watched a single bee go down the vine from flower to flower. It was in and out of each one before the flower had finished nodding. When it lifted off the last of them and went away over the highway, there was nothing on the bank to show it had been there. He tied the neck of the bag and carried it in.

Background

The verse

> *As the bee collects nectar and departs without injuring the flower, or its colour or scent, so let a sage dwell in his village.*
>
> Dhammapada 49, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Kosiya is a rich man of the town of Sakkhara ("Jaggery," raw sugar) who never gives away so much as a drop of oil. Seeing a hungry countryman eat a filled cake, he craves one, hides the craving for fear of having to share, and finally has his wife cook for him alone at the top of his seven-storied house behind bolted doors. The Buddha sends the elder Mahā Moggallāna, who stands in the air outside the window, walks, sits, and pours out smoke as the miser dares him to. The cakes swell and stick together; the miser sweats his craving away, gives up the whole basket, and is carried with his wife down his own staircase to the Jetavana monastery, where the cakes feed five hundred monks and never run out. The leftovers are thrown down by the gate at a place afterward called Fried Cake Mountain. The verse is the Buddha's praise of Moggallāna, who won the household without harming its faith or its wealth. An attached birth story tells of the miser Illīsa, who broke seven generations of family generosity until his dead father came back wearing his face. Read the full commentary story, or about Moggallāna.

Scott County, Mississippi

Central Mississippi, August 2019

On August 7, 2019, immigration agents raided seven chicken processing plants in six central Mississippi towns, among them Morton, Forest, Carthage and Canton, and arrested 680 workers. It was the largest workplace raid in a single state in American history, and it fell on the first day of school. About three hundred people were released within a day, many of them parents of small children, some wearing GPS ankle monitors; hundreds more were sent to detention centers in Louisiana. The plants had been recruiting Latin American workers for decades, and many of those arrested were Maya from Guatemala's western highlands, the departments of San Marcos and Huehuetenango, where Mam is spoken. With paychecks gone overnight, parish halls and mission churches became kitchens, food pantries and legal clinics for months; see reporting in The Intercept and Mississippi Catholic. Ribbon Cane, the mission, and every person in the story are invented.

In highland Maya towns the patron saint's festival was traditionally paid for by householders who took the burden in turn, a round of offices known as the cargo system; a man who carried it fed the town and could be left in debt for years. Lay catechists and Delegates of the Word have led rural Central American congregations where priests are scarce since the 1960s, and many were killed or driven out in Guatemala in the early 1980s. Catarina's book is the *Introduction to the Devout Life* (1609) of St. Francis de Sales, bishop of Geneva, long read in Spanish as the *Filotea*; the line about the bee is quoted from the nineteenth-century English translation in the Christian Classics Ethereal Library. A tayuyo is a Guatemalan corn cake stuffed with black beans. Kudzu blooms in Mississippi in late summer.

After the story of the selfish Kosiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 49). The original. Scripture from St. Francis de Sales, *Introduction to the Devout Life* (nineteenth-century English translation), and the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

4.6

The Limbertwig

Tain't my mother or my father, but it's me, O Lord,
Standin' in the need of prayer.
— "It's Me, O, Lord," as printed in 1925

The way it come down to me, in the trailer camp below the Turnpike.

I. The Boy from Home

Middletown trailer camp, Oak Ridge, Tennessee · October 1944

Ina Ledford had a trailer in Row F of the Middletown camp, a husband on the pipe gangs at K-25, a boy of eleven, and a stool in front of a board at Y-12. Besides these she had Arvil Tallent.

Arvil was twenty-three and came from Englewood, the same as the Ledfords. He had been called to preach at fifteen, in a brush arbor behind the hosiery mill, and no church had called him since. The Army would not have him on account of an eardrum. He drove nails on the hutment crews and slept in a hutment with four other men, and he ate at Ina's table. She washed his shirts in the bathhouse tubs along with Carl's and turned his collars when they frayed. She saved him the top of the milk and what sugar the stamps allowed. When people in the row asked was he her boy, she said he was the same as.

In return he told her things. He knew who in the camp drank, and who danced on the tennis courts by the recreation hall, and which trailer had a woman in it who was nobody's wife. He knew what the foremen let slide. He knew, he said, what they were making over the ridge, and he would lean across the oilcloth and all but say it, with a billboard up on the Turnpike telling every soul who passed to leave what they saw here where they saw it. Ina took it in with her supper. She had been raised to

think that a man who could name what was wrong with everybody stood closer to God than the rest of them.

On Thursday nights, when the last wash was wrung out, there was a meeting in Bathhouse Seven. Mrs. Sisk went, from the trailer on the left, and Mrs. Hembree from the trailer on the right, and they came back along the plank walk at ten o'clock both talking at once. The woman who held it was the woman who kept the bathhouse. Her name was Docia Brakebill, and the camp called her Aunt Docia. All day she mopped the concrete and fed the water heater. On Thursdays she turned a washtub over to sit on and talked a while, and then they sang.

I never heard it laid out so plain, Mrs. Sisk said. *Not at home. Not anywhere.*

Ina wanted to go. She put it to Arvil the way she would have asked leave of a pastor.

Don't go, he said.

She asked the next week, and the week after.

She mops a bathhouse. She belongs to no church I ever heard of, and a woman has no call to hold a meeting. Don't go.

Ina thought it over at her board, between readings. If she was not to go to the old woman, nobody had said the old woman could not come to her.

II. The Errand

Saturday evening

She was on the three-to-eleven that week. Before she left for the bus she gave Doyle his orders. *Go tell Miss Docia I'd be proud to have her to dinner tomorrow. Tell her Row F, the fourteenth one down, with the lard can of marigolds on the step.*

Doyle went by the hutments first. He generally did. Arvil was on his cot with his shoes off.

Where are you headed?

Mama sent me to ask Miss Docia to dinner.

Don't go.

I've got to. She'll skin me.

There's a stack cake, isn't there. And a chicken. Arvil sat up. *You and me could eat all that ourselves. Don't go.*

She'll whip me, Arvil.

Arvil studied about it. *Go on, then. But don't tell her the row, and don't tell her how many down, and don't say marigolds. Let on like you live right there by the bathhouse. And when you leave, cut out toward the Turnpike like you were going someplace else, and then come back here.*

Doyle did it just that way. The old woman was wringing a mop into the floor drain. She heard him out and said she would be glad to come, and she did not ask him one thing. He ran off toward the Turnpike and came back around the coal pile to the hutments.

What did you do?

Everything you said.

You did fine. Now it's you and me that eats it.

III. The Fourteenth One Down

Sunday

Arvil came before daylight, while Carl was on his shift and Ina was down at the bathhouse filling the water can, and he took the boy in behind the curtain where the bed was.

The women of the row had been at it since Friday. Mrs. Sisk had scrubbed the linoleum with lye soap. Mrs. Hembree carried over the only stuffed chair in Row F, with a doily pinned to the back of it. There were five kinds of flowers in fruit jars: marigolds and zinnias, goldenrod, ironweed, and the small late asters that people there call farewell-summer. Three households had gone in together on the sugar.

There were close to four thousand trailers in Oak Ridge that fall. The ones at Middletown stood in rows on scraped red clay, every one like the next, with a plank walk down the middle and the numbers mostly gone from the doors. Men who had lived in the camp a year walked into the wrong kitchen after dark. In October the fog came up off the creek bottom and stood in the rows until nine.

Aunt Docia got down off the work bus from Oliver Springs at seven, with her badge pinned to her coat. She did not stop at the bathhouse to ask anybody. Mrs. Sisk was out on her step ready to wave, and she said afterward that she never got her hand up. The old woman came along the plank walk through the fog, past thirteen trailers, and did not turn her head to one of them. At the fourteenth she stepped off the planks, looked down a minute at the marigolds in the lard can, and knocked.

Ina poured water over her hands from the dipper, since there was no tap, and held the towel for her, and put her in the stuffed chair. At noon she set down fried chicken and soup beans and cornbread, and leather britches cooked with a piece of side meat, and then the stack cake, six layers, with dried apples between. Aunt Docia ate like a woman who had worked every day since she was six. When she was done she looked out the little window over the table.

There was a Limbertwig stood right about where your step is, she said. *My daddy set it out the year I was born. This was his upper corn ground, all through here. That bathhouse is sitting in the orchard.*

They told us it was all cleared off, Ina said.

They hung a paper on our door in November, and we were gone by Christmas. They pulled the house down, and they scraped the ground and graveled it and stood these things on it in rows. And it is every bit of it right where it was. I couldn't get lost in here if I tried.

Then she returned thanks. She had a sweet voice, old as she was, and she did not hurry it. She gave thanks for the chicken and for the hands that fried it, and went on from there to what a person is given and what a person does with it, and Ina, listening, said *That's so,* and then *That's so* again, right out loud, as she never had in any church.

The curtain came down off its nails.

She is none of mine anymore, Arvil said. He was white around the mouth. *You're lost, Ina. You old fool, sitting there saying amen to a mop woman.* He had more than that, and it was for both of them. He spoke of women who set up to teach, and of people who could not so much as hold on to the place they were born, and of what he was owed for two years of telling

the truth at that table. Then he went out the door and up the plank walk with one arm in his coat.

Doyle stood where the curtain had been.

Aunt Docia took up where she had left off. But Ina's face was red to the hair and her hands were working in her lap, and none of it reached her.

Can't you keep your mind on what I'm saying, honey?

No, ma'am. What he said has got me all to pieces.

Don't study a man like that. He has eaten off the leavings of other people's plates all his life, and other people's doings are all he has to chew on. Don't study what anybody else has done, nor what they've let go undone. You look to what you've done your own self, and what you've let go.

And she sang it, low, there at the table, with her hand keeping the time on the oilcloth.

> *It's me, it's me, it's me, O Lord,*
> *Standin' in the need of prayer.*
>
> *Tain't my mother or my father, but it's me, O Lord,*
> *Standin' in the need of prayer.*
>
> *Tain't the deacon or my leader, but it's me, O Lord,*
> *Standin' in the need of prayer.*
>
> *— "It's Me, O, Lord," The Book of American Negro Spirituals (1925)*

Ina said afterward that it was like the needle on her board, when it quits hunting and stands.

IV. The Board

Y-12 · that night, and the next August

They had trained her for three weeks in a room the girls called the Bullpen. Nobody there said what the machine was for. A man told them he could teach them what to do and could not tell them what they were doing, and after that it was all knobs and gauges. Her knobs had letters on them. When M was right and G was right, the

NEEDLE STOOD UP WHERE IT BELONGED. WHEN SHE LET IT GET away, the unit let go with a pop, and a blue light came on, and the floor men ran. *Keep yours where it goes,* the supervisor said. *Don't study on it, and don't study the next girl's.*

Ina had always studied the next girl's. The one on her right was from Lenoir City and popped twice a shift. Ina could have told you each time, and how long the floor men took, and what the supervisor's face did. She kept a kind of account of that whole row.

That night a blue light came on two boards down, and then one on her right, and feet went by behind her stool. Her hand stayed on the knob. Her needle stood. She did not know until the shift changed at eleven whose it had been.

• • •

On the sixth of August the Knoxville paper said in tall letters what had been made at Oak Ridge and where it had been put down. Horns blew on the Turnpike until dark. In Row F everybody was out on the plank walk telling what the scientists had done, and the Army, and the Japanese, and what Arvil Tallent would say he had known all along, now that he was preaching in McMinn County.

Ina sat on her step by the lard can. She had her right hand open in her lap, the thumb and two fingers a little apart, the width of a knob, and she was looking at it.

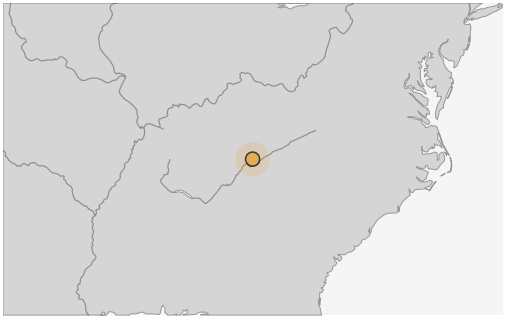
Background

The verse

> *Not the perversities of others, not their sins of commission or omission, but his own misdeeds and negligences should a sage take notice of.*
>
> Dhammapada 50, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a housewife of Sāvatthī keeps a naked ascetic named Pāṭhika, of the fatalist Ājīvika order, and looks after him like a son. When her neighbors praise the Buddha she asks leave to go and hear him, and Pāṭhika forbids it, so she sends

her boy to invite the Buddha to her house instead. The ascetic coaches the boy to hide where the house is, meaning to eat the meal himself, but a Buddha needs no directions and comes straight to the door. Hearing her applaud the teaching, Pāṭhika bursts out of the back room, abuses them both and runs off. She is too shaken to listen, and the Buddha tells her to leave other people's doings alone and look to her own. Read the full commentary story.



Oak Ridge, Tennessee

Oak Ridge, 1944

In the autumn of 1942 the Army took some 59,000 acres of Anderson and Roane counties for the Clinton Engineer Works. More than a thousand families were living there, on farms and in hamlets such as Elza, Robertsville and Scarboro. Some came home to find the notice nailed to the door or to a tree; most were given six weeks to leave and some only two. Many of the people put off the land later took jobs inside the fence. The town built over their fields held 75,000 people by 1945. Workers who earned the least were assigned to hutments and to nearly four thousand trailers, which had no bathrooms; families used shared bathhouses and carried their water. One of the camps, Middletown, stood along the Oak Ridge Turnpike. Bathhouse Seven, its Thursday meeting, Aunt Docia and the Ledfords are invented.

At the Y-12 plant, Tennessee Eastman hired about ten thousand women, most of them just out of East Tennessee high schools, to run the calutrons that separated uranium-235. These cubicle operators were trained for three weeks and told nothing of the purpose. A manager is remembered as saying, "We can train you how to do what is needed, but cannot tell you what you are doing." They sat on stools before tall boards and kept needles in place with lettered knobs. In a week-long production race against physicists from Berkeley, the women won; the physicists could not stop investigating every flicker of a dial. Most operators learned what they had made on August 6, 1945. The song Aunt Docia sings is an African American spiritual of unknown origin. It was recorded by the Elkins-Payne Jubilee Singers in 1923 and by a white West Virginia string band in 1927 (see the Traditional Ballad Index), and its

words are given here as James Weldon Johnson and J. Rosamond Johnson printed them in *The Book of American Negro Spirituals* in 1925.

After the story of the Ājīvaka Pāṭhika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 50). The original. Song text from The Book of American Negro Spirituals (1925). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

4·7

Besobila

Very different is the word of practice from words of beauty.
— Isaac of Nineveh, tr. A. J. Wensinck (1923)

Endih semichalehu, on Kennedy Street.

I. The Floor

Kennedy Street NW, Washington, D.C. · June 1991, the Fast of the Apostles

The Emahoy Wolete-Tsion lived in the basement of a brick rowhouse on Kennedy Street, in one room with a radiator and a window at the level of the grass. She had been a nun for fifty years, in a convent in Gojjam and afterward wherever the times put her. A deacon named Desta, who drove a cab at night, carried what she needed down the outside steps. On the mornings of fast days people left their shoes on those steps and sat on her floor, and she had the deacon read from the books of the monks, and then she told them in plain Amharic what had been read.

The one who sat nearest was Ato Tilahun. At home he had gone through the four houses of the books under a master at Gondar, the Old Testament and the New, the Fathers and the Monks, and had come out the far end without taking so much as a deacon's orders. He had been a clerk of a court. In Washington he sat from eleven at night until seven in the morning in the cashier's booth of a hotel garage on K Street. He carried a long black umbrella with a crook handle in every weather, as a church scholar at home carries one against the sun, and Washington rained often enough to make an honest man of him. He kept the fasts, though it was hard to say that he kept them, since he had eaten once a day, after three in the afternoon, for so many years that a fast day and a

feast day looked the same on him. People said of Tilahun that he had finished with most things.

On a Friday three weeks after the Derg fell, he was in his place with his legs folded and the umbrella laid along the wall. The deacon was reading. The room was full.

Dejazmach Workneh came down the steps.

He had governed a district in the south for the Emperor, and had got out in 1974 with his life and two suitcases. Now he had eleven parking lots between Dupont Circle and Foggy Bottom, and the men who worked them stood up when his car came down the ramp, as men had stood in the south. Since the end of May his telephone had not stopped. In every restaurant on Eighteenth Street the old families were handing one another back their lands. He took off his shoes like anyone and stooped under the lintel, and the room got to its feet, the women pulling their shawls straight, the young men flattening against the wall to make him a road.

Tilahun saw him come. He asked himself whether to rise, and he answered himself. The deacon was reading of the King of Kings. The country had once lent that name to a man, and the man was sixteen years dead, and nobody could say where the soldiers had put him. To stand up now, in the middle of the reading, for someone who had kept one of that man's districts would be to honor the district. He stayed as he was.

The Dejazmach saw it. The blood came up in his face. But he bowed low to the Emahoy and sat down against the side wall, where a place was made for him.

The Emahoy had seen both things. When the reading was finished she spoke across the room.

Dejazmach, this Tilahun is a man of sense. He knows the books, all four houses of them. I have known him in a good year and in a bad one, and I could not have told you from his face which was which.

She went on a little in that way, and as she went on, the Dejazmach's face eased.

II. The Lot

L Street · a wet morning, the week after

His office was a room up one flight at the back of his largest lot, with a window over the cars. He was standing at it after his coffee when he saw a black umbrella coming across the asphalt between the rows, and under it a small man in a raincoat, walking as if the lot were a churchyard.

Bring me that one, he told the attendant.

Tilahun came up the stairs. On the landing he closed the umbrella and stood it in the corner. He took off his shoes and set them beside it, and went in in his socks, and bowed, and stood to one side.

Why have you left your umbrella and your shoes outside my door?

They said to me, the Dejazmach is calling you. I put them down before I came in.

Then it seems that today you have found out who I am.

I have always known who the Dejazmach is.

If that is so, then on Friday, when you were on the Emahoy's floor and saw me come in, why did you not get up?

Dejazmach, I was sitting where the King of Kings was being read. If I had got up for the governor of one of His districts, it is the governor I would have honored, and not Him. So I did not get up.

The Dejazmach looked out at his cars for a time.

Let it go, he said. *They tell me you know this world and the other one, and all the books. My wife and my brother's widow want to learn. Come to my house and read to them.*

I cannot, Dejazmach.

Why can you not?

A great man's house is watched. What is fitting there and what is not fitting both weigh double.

Don't tell me that. You saw fit to keep your seat in front of me. Don't put this on top of it.

Dejazmach, it is a fault in a layman to go about doing the work of those who are under orders. Send for one of them, and ask him.

Very well. You may go.

Tilahun bowed and went out and put on his shoes on the landing. The Dejazmach watched the umbrella open at the foot of the stairs and go off toward the bus.

III. Tuesdays and Thursdays

A house off Sixteenth Street · that summer

He sent to Kennedy Street. *My wife, Woizero Abebech, and my brother's widow, Woizero Aster, say they wish to learn the books. Come to my house each week, Emahoy, and bring as many of your people as you like.*

The answer came back by the deacon. *It is not possible for me to go regularly to any one house.*

Then send someone.

She gave it to Desta. He was twenty-six, and had the Psalter by heart and a good deal of Mar Yishaq. On Tuesdays and Thursdays he parked his cab under the Dejazmach's oak and read to the two women in the front room and told them what it meant.

Woizero Aster came of an old house, the same house as the Emahoy, and had married into another. She kept a green ledger for the lessons and wrote in it with a fountain pen, in a hand like print. When there were guests she could give back any passage, with the deacon's explanation after it, and the guests said they had not heard it better in Addis Ababa. She kept the front room in flowers from the supermarket, roses on long stems and carnations dyed blue, and changed them every week. A person could put his whole face in them and smell the refrigerator.

Woizero Abebech was a gardener's daughter from the Entoto road, twenty years younger than the Dejazmach, and he had married her in a rented hall in 1980. She wrote nothing down. She said each lesson over to herself at the griddle until she had it, and then she seemed to carry it about the house looking for somewhere to put it. After the reading on mercy she began sending a covered pot down to L Street on fast days at three o'clock, for the men in the booths. After the reading on anger she telephoned a cousin of her husband's to whom she had not spoken in six

years. Nobody asked her to recite. On the back step, in olive-oil tins, she grew besobila from seed that someone had carried through customs in a sock. It was a weed to look at, gray-green, with dusty flowers. A person smelled it from the alley.

By the end of August nobody on Eighteenth Street was handing out provinces. The new men in Addis Ababa had set up their government, and the old families had not been sent for. Some Thursdays the Dejazmach sat in on the lesson, on a chair by the door, and said nothing.

IV. The Calendar

Kennedy Street · September, before the New Year

DESTA, THE EMAHOY SAID, *ARE YOUR TWO LADIES LEARNING?*

They are, Emahoy.

Which of them learns it well?

Woizero Abebech learns it well, and says it over, and it gets into what she does. But your own kinswoman does not learn it that way. She writes it. She does not say it over. I cannot find where any of it has gone.

Woizero Aster had sent two dozen roses down with him that morning, in paper. They stood in the mop bucket by the door. On the wall over the radiator hung a calendar from an Ethiopian grocery, with a color picture of the falls of the Abay, the river coming over brown and white. It had hung there three years and had not wet the plaster.

The Emahoy looked from the bucket to the wall. Then she began the place in Mar Yishaq, and he knew it, and said it with her.

> *Very different is the word of practice from words of beauty. Even without experience wisdom knows how to adorn its words and to speak the truth even without having any acquaintance with it, and to express itself concerning excellence without any experience of [practical] performance. A word proceeding from practice, is a treasure to confide in. But idle wisdom is a pawn causing shame; it is as when an artist paints water on walls, without being able to quench his thirst by it; or as a man who dreams beautiful dreams.*
>
> *— Isaac of Nineveh, Mystic Treatises I, tr. A. J. Wensinck (1923)*

Take her that, the Emahoy said. *Take it to both of them.*

• • •

On the morning of the New Year the room was full to the steps. Tilahun was in his place, with the umbrella along the wall. The Dejazmach came down in his socks with the two women behind him, and the room stood, and Tilahun stood with it, there being nothing read just then. Woizero Aster had brought yellow chrysanthemums, since the Meskel daisy does not grow in Washington, and they were set in the bucket where everyone could see them. Woizero Abebech had a twist of newspaper. She put it in the Emahoy's lap, and the Emahoy opened it.

People were still coming down from the street. They lifted their heads on the third step, before they could see the door.

Background

The verses

> *Like a beautiful flower, full of colour, but without scent, are the fine but fruitless words of him who does not act accordingly.*
>
> Dhammapada 51, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But, like a beautiful flower, full of colour and full of scent, are the fine and fruitful words of him who acts accordingly.*
>
> Dhammapada 52, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Chattapāṇi ("Umbrella-in-Hand") is a learned layman of Sāvatthī, far advanced on the path, who eats one meal a day. Seated before the Buddha, he does not rise when King Pasenadi comes in, reasoning that to stand for a provincial king in the presence of the king of kings would honor the wrong one. The Buddha praises him and the king's anger cools. Later the king sees him crossing the palace court with umbrella and sandals, has him called up, and asks him to teach the women of the palace; Chattapāṇi declines, saying that is work for a monk. The Buddha, who cannot go regularly to any one house, sends Ānanda. Queen Mallikā, a garland-maker's daughter, learns and practices; Queen Vāsabhakhattiyā, the Buddha's own kinswoman, does not; and the Buddha speaks the two verses of the flower. Read the full commentary story.

Washington, D.C.

Washington, 1991

The Ethiopian community of Washington, the largest outside Africa, began with those who left after the military council called the Derg deposed Emperor Haile Selassie in September 1974. The Emperor, whose title was *Neguse Negest*, King of Kings, was killed in August 1975, and his remains were not found until 1992. In the 1980s the exiles gathered around Eighteenth Street in Adams Morgan, and many who had been officials, officers and landholders at home drove cabs or worked in parking garages. The city's oldest Orthodox congregations date from those years; Debre Selam Kidist Mariam was founded in 1987. In May 1991 the Derg's ruler fled and rebel armies entered Addis Ababa, and for a season some exiles thought they might go home to what they had lost. Dejazmach was a title of the old nobility, often borne by provincial governors. Emahoy is how a nun is addressed. Everyone in this story is invented.

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church fasts on Wednesdays and Fridays and through long seasons, among them the Fast of the Apostles after Pentecost; on a fast day nothing is eaten before three in the afternoon. Its traditional schools teach commentary on four bodies of books: the Old Testament, the New, the Fathers, and the

Books of the Monks. First among the last is Mar Yishaq, the seventh-century Syriac hermit Isaac of Nineveh, whose treatises reached Ethiopia by way of Arabic. The passage here is from the opening treatise as A. J. Wensinck translated it from the Syriac in 1923; the Ethiopic wording differs. Besobila is Ethiopian sacred basil, a plain plant with a strong sweet smell, dried into the spice blends of every kitchen.

After the story of the lay disciple Chattapāṇi from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 51 and 52). The original. Scripture from Isaac of Nineveh, Mystic Treatises, translated by A. J. Wensinck (1923). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

4.8

Yesterday's Bread

The rainstorm smiteth it and it bringeth forth its fruit twofold.
— Qur'an 2:265

Heik sme't, on Dix Avenue in the Southend.

I. The Station

Toledo, Ohio · 1953

When Nawal Darwish was seven years old, an old sheikh from the south of Lebanon came through the Midwest on the train, stopping wherever there were enough Muslims to fill a front room. He had been in Michigan City and Cedar Rapids and would go on to Detroit. In Toledo the Lebanese had been waiting for him a month. Her grandfather, Hajj Mahmoud, who had started with a peddler's pack and now owned the biggest wholesale grocery in the city, said to her that morning, *This is a good day for you and a good day for me. Put on your white dress and take your cousins and go and meet him.*

Her uncle drove the girls to the new terminal in the Packard. He pulled up at the curb in front and they all started to climb out, and Nawal said, *No, Uncle, you have to drive us around to where the trains are,* and he did, as far as cars were allowed to go. Then she got out and walked the rest of the way across the platform with her cousins behind her, and stood a little to one side, and waited. When the sheikh came down the steps of the car with his cane, he looked at the girl in the white dress waiting at exactly the right distance, and smiled, and spoke to her, and nobody remembered afterward what he said, only that she listened to all of it.

Her grandfather fed the sheikh for two weeks at his long table on Bancroft Street, and half of Lebanese Toledo came to listen.

A few years later the big man of the Southend in Dearborn, Abu Jamal, who ran a coffeehouse, a travel agency and half the votes on Dix Avenue, came down to Toledo and sat in Hajj Mahmoud's parlor. *You have five rich families here,* he said, *and in Dearborn we have the Rouge and the smoke and men who work double shifts and not one family like yours. Give me one of them. I won't go home without one.* The old men of Toledo talked it over and told him to take Kamal, Hajj Mahmoud's eldest, Nawal's father. Kamal said, *If you send me, I'll go.*

But when he drove up to the Southend and saw it, the houses jammed against the plant fence and the soot on the laundry, he said to Abu Jamal, *My family is a large one. Your Southend is full. Let me settle out here,* and bought land out past Telegraph Road where the subdivisions were still going up in the cornfields, and built a big brick house, and moved his trucks and his warehouse after it.

II. The Rain

Belle Isle, Detroit · August 1964

In the Southend lived Hajj Rida Khalifeh, who owned four markets and a Pontiac dealership on Michigan Avenue and was the richest man between the Rouge and the river, and he had a son named Hassan who had just finished at Wayne State and did not want to get married.

Choose anybody you like, his mother said. *A house with no children falls down.*

Hassan said that he would marry when they found him a girl with the five beauties, and not before. Beautiful hair, that fell to the hem of her skirt and curled up at the ends. Lips like a ripe pomegranate. Teeth like a row of pearls. Skin that needed no powder. And a youth that would stay on her, if she had ten children, as if she had had one.

So his mother sent out her two sisters, who had married off half the Southend between them, with money for the bus and the train and a gold

necklace in a velvet box. *When you find her, put it on her.* The aunts went to Toledo and Cleveland and Cedar Rapids and as far as Quincy, Massachusetts, and saw a great many lovely girls, and none of them had all five. They came home tired at the end of the summer, on the Sunday of the big Lebanese picnic on Belle Isle, and went to it, and sat down in the stone pavilion out of the sun and fanned themselves.

Nawal was seventeen. She came along the path from the river in a green dress, with her cousins and her friends around her, thirty girls at least, with her hair down her back. When they were halfway across the grass the sky over Canada turned purple, and a wind came off the river and turned the leaves over white, and then the rain came down all at once, the way it does in August, in sheets.

Every girl on the grass shrieked and ran for the pavilion holding her purse over her head. Nawal walked. She came in at the same pace she had been walking before, and her dress was wet through and her hair was streaming, and her gold bracelets were running with water.

The aunts saw four of the beauties right there. One of them said to the other, loud enough to carry, *That one's lazy. Her husband will be lucky to get a cup of tea out of her.*

What did you say? said Nawal. They said afterward her voice was like a bell in a church across a valley.

We said all your friends ran in out of the rain and stayed dry, and it was only twenty steps, and you came strolling in like the Queen of England, and look at you.

Khalto, I'm stronger than any of them, she said. *And I had my reasons. There are four people who never look well running. A king, in all his medals, running across his courtyard. People will say, why is the king running like a delivery boy? A fine horse in a parade, all dressed up. A sheikh, in his robe and turban. And a woman. People will say, look at her, running like a man.*

And the other reason?

A girl's mother and father raise her to give her away to another family. Let's be honest, we're merchandise. If I run on wet grass and fall and break my wrist, I'm a burden to my father. A dress dries.

She smiled when she said it, and the aunts saw her teeth.

They got up together. They put the gold necklace around Nawal's wet neck, there in the pavilion, in front of everybody. *Only you,* they said.

She asked them where they were from and whose house had sent them. *Hajj Rida Khalifeh, of the Southend. For his son Hassan.* She thought: a family like ours. And she sent one of her cousins to the parking lot for her father's car, because from the moment that necklace was on her neck she was not going to walk home.

Her father asked the aunts what Hajj Rida was worth. They told him, with some pride. *Next to us,* he said, *that's small change. But when a man finds a good house for his daughter, what else is there to count?* He gave his consent and kept the aunts two days as his guests and sent them home in his own car with the trunk full of presents.

III. The Peacock

Out past Telegraph Road · the winter of 1964

Hajj Rida wrote that he would come to fetch the bride himself, and that Abu Jamal would come with him out of respect, and half the Southend with Abu Jamal, and could the house manage? Kamal Darwish wrote back: *If ten Abu Jamals are coming, let them come.*

They came after Thanksgiving, two hundred people in a line of cars, and Kamal put up every one of them. It was Nawal, at seventeen, who sat at the kitchen table with a pencil and decided who would sleep in which house up and down the new street and who would carry coffee to whom, so that nobody could say afterward that they came to Nawal Darwish's wedding and spent it parking cars.

Kamal had sent for an Armenian goldsmith from downtown and told him to make his daughter a set of bridal gold such as Detroit had never seen. Then the snow came, the first big storm of that winter, and closed the roads, and Kamal told Abu Jamal, *Nobody leaves this house until I say so,* and kept them all until the gold was finished, which was not until February. For three months that subdivision was one long party. Everybody from Abu Jamal down to the boys who parked the cars thought he was the guest of honor. When the fuel oil ran out in the cold snap in January

and no truck could get through, Kamal had his men pull down the old barn that had come with the land and burn it in the furnaces, and when that was gone he had them open the warehouse and soak rags in cooking oil, and they burned those.

The gold was finished at last. It went from the crown of her head to her feet, a lace of gold chain and coral and pearls fastened at the brow and the ears and the throat and the wrists and the waist, and on the crown of her head stood a peacock of gold with a thousand feathers, every feather on its own fine wire, so that when she moved her head they shivered and chimed, and you had to stand close to be sure it was not alive.

Then her father gave her the rest: silver, dishes, sewing machines, bolts of cloth, a truck full of rice and flour and oil and a truck full of tools, *so that in the house where she's going she will never have to send next door and ask to borrow anything.* He told his foreman to count out twenty sheep from the farm in Monroe for her wedding feast and shut the gate, and the men swore that sixty jumped the fence and ran down the road after the truck and would not be turned back.

The night before she left, her father sat her down in his study with the door half open and gave her his advice. Hajj Rida was in the next room and heard every word of it.

Daughter. In your husband's house, don't carry the fire from inside to outside. Don't carry the fire from outside to inside. Give to the one who gives back. Don't give to the one who doesn't. Give to the one who gives back and the one who doesn't. Sit happy. Eat happy. Sleep happy. Tend the fire. And honor the ones the house stands on.

In the morning he called eight of the oldest men of the Toledo families out onto the snowy lawn in front of everybody and said, *If anything is ever said against my daughter in that house, you will settle it.* Then he put her in the white Cadillac. And when the people who worked for him in the warehouse and drove his trucks and had known Nawal since she was a child heard that she was going, a good many of them got into their own cars and fell in behind, and the line of them went back half a mile.

Hajj Rida, at the back of the procession, asked who all those people were. *They want to work for the bride. Who's going to feed all of them?* He got out on Telegraph Road and shouted them back, and let come only the ones who would not go. Nawal said, *Leave them, they'll earn their own bread and yours too,* and he did not listen.

At the city line she had the top put down, in February, and stood up in the back of the open Cadillac in all her gold with the peacock on her head, and rode standing the whole length of Dix Avenue past the coffeehouses and the mosque and the plant gates, so the whole Southend could see what it had got. The men came out of the coffeehouses with their cards still in their hands.

Every family in the Southend sent her a present that week. She sent every one of them on to somebody else, to a widow on Salina Street, a family just off the boat, an old man in a rented room, each with a message in her own words: *This is for my mother. This is for my uncle. This is for my little sister.* By the end of the week she had made half the Southend her relations.

IV. Yesterday's Bread

The Khalifeh house, the Southend · spring 1965

HAJJ RIDA DID NOT ASK THE OLD SHEIKH TO THE WEDDING, though the sheikh was living in two rooms over the mosque on Vernor Highway, ten minutes' walk away. Hajj Rida had his own holy man. His name was Abu Khalil, and he read coffee cups and wrote charms on paper for a price, and sat in Hajj Rida's best chair in his undershirt with his belly over his belt, with five or six hangers-on around him who laughed when he laughed.

In the spring Hajj Rida gave Abu Khalil and his friends a dinner. He had lamb cooked in the yard and rice with pine nuts in the big trays, and when they were eating he sent upstairs for his son's wife. *Tell the bride to come down and kiss the hand of the holy man.*

She came down glad, when she heard the words holy man. She stood in the dining room door and looked at Abu Khalil, the undershirt, the

grease on his chin, the coffee cups upended on their saucers on the tablecloth, the money folded under one of them. *These have no shame at all,* she said, *and no fear of God either. Why would you call that holy, Uncle? Why would you send for me for this?* And she went back upstairs.

Hajj, said Abu Khalil, *that girl is bad luck. I see it in the grounds. Put her out of the house.*

Hajj Rida thought: I can't put Kamal Darwish's daughter in the street because a cup-reader says so. *She's young,* he said. *The young say things. Let it go.*

The next morning he sat alone at the head of the table with honey and fresh bread and white cheese and a silver coffee pot, and Nawal stood beside him pouring his coffee. An old man knocked at the open door. Everyone in the Southend knew him. He went round every week with a tin can, collecting for the mosque and for men hurt in the plant.

Nawal stepped aside so that her father-in-law could see the old man. Hajj Rida saw him. He looked down at his plate and went on eating, as if there were nobody at the door.

Nawal went to the door herself. *Go on to the next house, uncle, God keep you,* she said. *My father-in-law is eating yesterday's bread.*

Hajj Rida threw down his napkin. *Take this away. Get that girl out of my house. In my own dining room she stands and tells the street I eat stale bread like a beggar.* But every maid and driver in that house had come in the line of cars behind the white Cadillac. Nobody moved. Nobody said a word.

Uncle, said Nawal, *I don't leave a house for a reason like that. You didn't find me on the beach. I have a father and a mother. My father knew this might happen and he put me in the hands of eight men in front of everybody. Send for them. Let them judge.*

She's right, said Hajj Rida, and he sent to Toledo, and the eight old men came up the next Sunday in their good suits.

I was eating my breakfast, Hajj Rida said, *and she told a man at my door I was eating stale bread.*

Is that so, daughter?

Not exactly. A man was at the door collecting for the mosque, and my father-in-law saw him and looked at his plate. And I thought: he isn't making any new

bread in this life. He's eating what was baked a long time ago, by whoever was good before him, and one day it will be gone. That's what I said. Where's the fault?

No fault. Hajj, why are you angry with her?

All right, there's no fault in that. But one night in the middle of the night she went out behind the house with the help, the men and the women both.

Daughter?

My father gave me a goat from the farm. She was kidding that night in the garage, and it was a hard birth. I didn't think it was right to lie in bed. So I had them bring flashlights, and we went out, and we pulled the kid, and I washed the mother with warm water.

Hajj, she does work in your house your maids wouldn't do. What's the fault?

All right. But the night before she came, her father gave her a lot of advice that I heard with my own ears, and I don't understand a word of it. Don't carry the fire from inside to outside. How do you live on a street and never lend your neighbor a match?

That isn't what he meant, said Nawal. *He meant if I see something wrong in my husband or my father-in-law, I don't carry it out of the house and tell it on the street. There's no fire like that one. And don't carry the fire from outside in means if the neighbors say something against this family, I don't bring it home and repeat it at the table.* And she went through the rest. Lend to the ones who return what they borrow, not to the ones who never do, but when your own poor come asking, give, whether they can pay or not. Sit happy, eat happy, sleep happy: stand when your elders come in, eat after they've eaten, go to bed after the house is put to bed. Tend the fire and honor the ones the house stands on: look after your husband and his parents the way you'd look after a stove you mean to keep lit.

Hajj Rida sat with his head down and said nothing.

Is there anything else against our daughter, Hajj?

No.

Then why do you want to put her out of your house for nothing?

Nawal stood up. *When I was accused, it wasn't right for me to go. Now you've said I'm clear, it's right.* And she told the maids to bring down her suitcases and the drivers to bring round the cars.

Hajj Rida stood up too. He asked the eight old men to sit down again. *My daughter,* he said, *I spoke without knowing. Forgive me.*

Uncle, I forgive you with all my heart. But I come from a house that can't live without the mosque and the old sheikh. If I can have him to this house whenever I like, and feed him and his people, I'll stay.

Feed him every day of the week, said Hajj Rida.

V. The Curtain

The same spring

She invited the sheikh for the following Friday, after the prayer. When Abu Khalil heard that the old sheikh was going to Hajj Rida's house, he and his friends came and sat on the porch and on the steps all round it like a ring of crows.

Nawal served the sheikh and his people with her own hands. Then she sent word to her father-in-law in the back room. *Uncle, everything is ready. Come and sit with the sheikh.*

Hajj Rida wanted to go. Abu Khalil leaned in the window and said, *Hajj, don't you go near that man,* and Hajj Rida sent word that his daughter-in-law could look after the guest by herself.

When the meal was finished she sent a second time. *Uncle, the sheikh is going to speak. Come and listen.*

Now Hajj Rida thought it would be a shame not to go, and he had wanted to hear the old man for years. *All right,* said Abu Khalil, *if you have to listen to him, listen from behind a curtain. Don't sit in the same room with him and don't look him in the face.* And Abu Khalil's friends went ahead of him and strung a bedsheet across the archway between the dining room and the parlor, and Hajj Rida sat down behind it on a kitchen chair.

The sheikh said, to nobody in particular, *A man can sit behind a curtain. He can sit behind a wall, or a mountain, or the edge of the world. If God wants him to hear, he hears.* And then he began to speak, quietly, in order, the way a man lays bricks.

Everyone in that house said afterward that the old man was looking at them alone and talking to them alone, the way everybody on a street thinks the moon is over his own house.

Behind the bedsheet Hajj Rida sat with his hands on his knees and listened, and something in him that had been shut since he was a boy in the old country came open. He lifted the corner of the sheet and came through, and went straight past the sheikh to his son's wife and took her face in both his hands and kissed her forehead, and then her hands.

From today, he said, *you are my mother.*

Then he went and knelt by the sheikh's chair and kissed his hands, and said his own name three times, *I am Rida Khalifeh, I am Rida Khalifeh, I am Rida Khalifeh,* as if he were telling it to somebody for the first time. *All my life I didn't know where a gift bears fruit. My daughter-in-law came into my house to save me.*

The next Friday it was his wife's turn. After that the Khalifeh house kept an open door, and the old man with the tin can never left it empty-handed again, and Abu Khalil found other people's cups to read.

Hajj Rida had a second set of gold made for her that spring, light enough to wear every day, asleep or awake, and Nawal wore it to her grave. When her first son was born she named him Rida. In the Southend for the rest of her life they called her Umm Rida, the mother of Rida, and some of the old men, who knew why, meant the old man as well as the boy.

VI. Two Fingers

Monroe County · the 1970s

SHE HAD TEN CHILDREN, FIVE SONS AND FIVE DAUGHTERS, AND they had children, and none of them in all those years was ever seriously sick, and none of them died young, and every family in the Southend asked Umm Rida first to their weddings and housewarmings, for the luck. People said she never got a gray hair. People said that when they saw her coming up the street with all her children and grandchildren around her they could not tell which one was Umm Rida.

She was strong, too, everyone knew, though nobody could say how strong. Abu Jamal, getting old and curious, wanted to find out. On the Eid one year, when half the Southend drove down to the farms in Monroe County for the sacrifice, he had the farmer let a young bull out of the pen while Umm Rida was crossing the yard with her daughters. The bull put its head down and came for her. Her daughters screamed and some of them ran and some of them held on to her.

What is this? she said.

Yumma, Abu Jamal let it out to see how strong you are.

She thought: if I grab him hard, I'll kill him. So she reached out and took the bull by the ring in its nose between two fingers and pushed, gently, and it sat down on its haunches in the mud in front of everybody. The men at the farm applauded, and she walked on to the car.

VII. The Gold on the Stair

Vernor Highway and the east side · 1980–1982

By 1980 the families were moving out of the Southend to the east side of Dearborn, along Warren Avenue, and new families were coming every month from Lebanon, where the war had been going on for five years, with nothing but what they could carry. The old sheikh was very old.

That spring there was a wedding, and after the wedding lunch the whole party walked over to the mosque on Vernor Highway for the sheikh's talk. Umm Rida had worn the great set, the peacock and all, for her niece's sake. At the mosque door she thought: it isn't right to walk into the house of God dressed like this. So she took it off and wrapped it in her shawl and gave it to Sakineh, the girl who looked after her, who was the only one strong enough to carry it, and put on her everyday gold, and went in and listened. When it was over she went out the side door, and Sakineh went with her, and forgot the bundle on the bench.

Abu Ali, who had kept the mosque for thirty years, always went round after a gathering to pick up what people had left behind. He found the shawl and what was in it and went to the sheikh. *Umm Rida forgot her gold.*

Put it somewhere safe. So he hung the bundle on the newel post at the foot of the stairs.

Umm Rida meanwhile went round the back rooms with Sakineh, the way she did after every gathering, asking the families just come from Beirut and Tyre, who slept there on the floor, what they needed, and writing it down. Then she went out by the back door, and on the sidewalk she said, *Sakineh, give me the set, I'll put it back on.* Sakineh put her hand over her mouth.

Go back and get it, said Umm Rida. *But if Abu Ali has already picked it up and put it away, don't bring it. Then I've given it to the mosque.*

Abu Ali told Sakineh where it was. *It's on the stair. Take it.* But Sakineh would not touch it. *Not after you've had it in your hands, uncle. My lady won't take it back.* And she went back to Umm Rida glad.

She's right, said Umm Rida. *I won't wear it again. But a peacock is no use to the mosque. Go and fetch it after all; I'll sell it and give them the money.*

She had the goldsmiths in to price it. No jeweler in Detroit could buy it at that price, or would try. So she wrote the check for it herself, and took the check to the sheikh.

Sheikh, Abu Ali touched my gold, and from that moment I couldn't wear it. I tried to sell it for you and nobody could buy it, so I bought it myself. Here is the money. What should it be?

The old man thought for a while. *Would it suit you,* he said, *to build something on the east side? Where the families are going.*

It suited her exactly. With part of the money she bought two lots on the east side, and with the rest she began to build: a prayer hall on the ground floor, and upstairs rooms where a family off the plane from Beirut could sleep in a real bed until they found their feet.

That autumn the sheikh told her he was going to Mecca for the Hajj. She went to him at the airport. *I'm building this for you, and you're leaving. Stay. This is a journey I don't turn back from, my daughter.* She thought: he has his reasons. *Then leave me one of your people who knows what's right and what isn't. Take whoever you want.*

She loved Abu Ali best. But she chose Kassem Fawaz, who ran the big crane at the Rouge, because everyone knew that Kassem could get any-

thing off the ground, and the sheikh nodded at him, and Kassem stayed. Kassem and his crew went out on Saturdays with flatbeds and came back the same day with steel and timber from places nobody could later find on a map, and no axle broke and no man got tired. In nine months the building stood two stories high. The sheikh came home the next June, just before Ramadan, after nine months on the road, and Umm Rida met him at the airport and made him promise to spend the whole of Ramadan there, and fed every soul who came in the door, every night of the month.

A friend of hers, Fatmeh Saad, came to her with a silk rug from Kashan worth more than her husband's house and asked where she could lay it. *If I tell you there's no room,* said Umm Rida, *you'll think I don't want your rug. Go and look for yourself.* Fatmeh went through the whole building, the hall and every room upstairs. Everywhere the carpet was better than hers. At the end of the hall she stood with her rug in her arms and cried, because there was no place in the house of God for what she had to give.

Abu Ali found her there. *Don't cry,* he said. *Come.* He took her downstairs to the washroom, where the men and women made their ablutions before prayer and came out barefoot and wet onto the bare tile. *Put it here,* he said, *between the water and the hall. Everybody who prays in this place will stand on it first.* It was the one place Umm Rida had forgotten.

VIII. The Garden on a Height

East Dearborn · the end of Ramadan, 1982

On the last night of Ramadan, when the building was finished and full of people, Umm Rida went out at sunset and walked round the outside of it, slowly, with her children and her grandchildren and the first of her great-grandchildren behind her in a long line. And as she walked she sang out loud, the way village women sing at a wedding. *When will I build a house of God, plastered and painted? Now it's done. When will I give the beds and the blankets? Now it's done. When will I feed the hungry at the breaking of the fast? Now it's done.*

In all those years nobody had ever heard Umm Rida sing. *Sheikh,* they said, *is she all right? Has something happened to her?*

She's not singing, said the old man. *She's saying thank you. She made a promise a long time ago, and it's kept, and her heart is full.*

What promise? When?

So he told them. How in his own village in the south, when he was a boy, the women sewed the prayer rugs for the mosque by hand, and one of them, an old widow named Hajjeh Zeinab, gave all her thread and all her needles and all her cloth, and asked for nothing for it but one thing. She knelt down on the last rug she finished and asked God to give her, one day, a granddaughter who would build Him a house with her own hands. *She was Umm Rida's great-grandmother,* said the sheikh. *And the little girl who stood on the platform in Toledo in her white dress was the same one, already. I knew her the minute I saw her.*

Then he said a verse they had all heard a hundred times.

> *The likeness of those who spend their wealth in Allah's way is as the likeness of a grain which groweth seven ears, in every ear a hundred grains. Allah giveth increase manifold to whom He will. Allah is All-Embracing, All-Knowing.*
>
> *— Qur'an 2:261*

Look at her, he said. *From one grain.*

The line came round the corner of the building in the dusk, the old woman at the front with her scarf over hair that had never gone gray, and her children, and her children's children, and behind them the families from upstairs who had come off the planes from Beirut that year and had fallen in at the end of the line without being asked, and the children of those families. There were so many by then that the front of the line had come all the way round to where the back of it had started. It went round and round the house. The people on the steps could not tell anymore where it began.

Inside, under the bare bulb in the washroom, the Kashan rug lay between the water and the prayer hall, dark with wet footprints, every one of them pointing the same way.

Background

The verse

> *As many kinds of wreaths can be made from a heap of flowers, so many good things may be achieved by a mortal when once he is born.*
>
> Dhammapada 53, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Visākhā meets the Buddha at seven and becomes a disciple. Her father is moved by royal request to a new city, and there envoys of the rich man Migāra, looking for a bride with the five beauties, see her walk calmly through a sudden rainstorm while her friends run, and hear her explain why. Her father gives her a dowry beyond counting, the jeweled "great-creeper" ornament with its golden peacock, ten riddling admonitions, and eight sponsors to judge her if she is ever accused. In Migāra's house she refuses to honor his naked ascetics and tells a monk at the door that her father-in-law is "eating stale food," living on old merit. Cleared by the sponsors, she stays on condition that she may serve the Buddha; Migāra, listening from behind a curtain, is converted and calls her his mother. Late in life she leaves her ornament at the monastery, buys it back herself, and with the money builds the Eastern Monastery, and on its opening day walks round it singing. The Buddha explains her vow from ages past and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Visākhā.

Dearborn, Michigan

Dearborn, 1953–1982

Arab immigrants, many of them from Lebanon, came to work at Ford's River Rouge complex and settled in Dearborn's Southend, in the shadow of the plant. Muslim Ford workers there built the American Moslem Society mosque on Vernor Highway, its first floor finished by 1937 and the rest added through the 1950s. Smaller Arab Muslim communities had grown up across the Midwest; in Cedar Rapids, Iowa, Le-

banese and Syrian immigrants finished the Mother Mosque of America in 1934, considered the oldest purpose-built mosque still standing in the United States.

Palestinian refugees began arriving after the 1967 war, and the Lebanese Civil War, which began in 1975, brought a long wave of families from Lebanon. According to the Dearborn Historical Museum, volunteers founded the social-service agency ACCESS in 1971, and from the late 1970s Arab Americans moved from the Southend to the east side of Dearborn, where by the 1990s a business district had grown along Warren Avenue. The Darwish and Khalifeh families, the sheikh, and the building on the east side are invented.

After the story of Visākhā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 53). The original. Scripture from the Qur'an in the translation of Marmaduke Pickthall (1930). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

4.9

The Contrary Wind

The name, that dwells on every tongue,
No minstrel needs.
— Jorge Manrique, Coplas, tr. H. W. Longfellow

Ansí lo oí dezir, on the river at Palos.

I. The Glass

The Ocean Sea, west of the Canaries · September 1492

They had been sent for spices. It was written so in the Admiral's papers from the King and Queen, along with pearls and gold and silver, a tenth of all of it to be his if he found the way. So the ship carried, besides her biscuit and salt meat and wine and forty men, a small locked box of the things they were looking for, to hold up in front of whoever lived at the other end. The box was in the keeping of the steward, an old man named Benito whom everybody aboard called Uclés, after the town he came from. He had the stores, the water casks, the lamp oil and the firebox. He had the ship's boys too, whenever nobody else was giving them orders.

Antón was one of the boys, fourteen years old, from Moguer. On his watch he kept the glass. When the sand ran out he turned it and sang the verse the boys sang at every turn, that the glass going was good and the glass coming better, and the helmsman answered him from below. Eight glasses made a watch. Between glasses he fetched for Uclés.

From the day they lost sight of Hierro the wind stood behind them. It blew out of the east, a little north of east, day and night, and the ship ran before it as if she were being led. The men should have been glad of that, and each day they were quieter. Antón heard them in the waist. They had

sailed to Guinea and to Flanders and to Chios, and not one of them had seen a wind sit in one quarter for two weeks together. How does a ship come home against that? they said. In this sea there is no wind for Spain.

The wind did a thing to the nose as well. The firebox stood forward, and with the wind aft the smoke and the smell of the pot went away over the bow and were gone. Back by the glass, Antón never once smelled his own dinner cooking. The men on the forecastle smelled the whole ship, the pitch and the bilge and the Admiral's lamp. Everything aboard went one way. He thought about it while the sand ran, having little else to think about.

On the twenty-second of September the wind came round ahead for one day. The ship labored, and the men cheered up like men let out of a cellar. The Admiral was heard to say that he had needed that contrary wind, because his people had come to believe that in these seas none ever blew toward Spain. Within a few days it was back in the east, and it stayed there.

II. The Box

At anchor off the Cabo Hermoso · the evening of 19 October

THEY HAD FOUND ISLANDS A WEEK BEFORE, AND PEOPLE ON them, and no spice that anyone could put a name to. At each landing the Admiral had Uclés bring out the box, and Antón carried it. Inside, in small linen bags, were sticks of cinnamon bark, a hand of ginger root, a measure of cloves and a measure of pepper. The island people smelled each bag with great courtesy and pointed south.

On the nineteenth they anchored off a cape so green that the Admiral named it the Beautiful Cape and could not decide which part of it to look at first. At sundown the wind fell. Then it came back off the land, the way it will at evening, and it brought the land out with it, a smell of flowers and trees so sweet that the men stopped talking. They said the *Salve* in their fashion, which was no two of them together. Afterward Antón sat down with the box, which he was to air before it was locked up for the night, and opened the bags one at a time.

Bark, he thought, and root, and flower, since a clove is a flower that has not opened. These are the three best smells in the world. The King and Queen have sent three ships after them. And every one of them goes down the wind and no other way. I have sat to windward of this box for six weeks and never known what was in it until the lid was up. Those flowers on the cape reach us because the wind is off the land. In the morning it will turn, and the land can smell us, God help it, and we will smell nothing. Is there anything in the world that goes the other way?

He turned it over until he saw that he was not going to settle it by himself. Then he did the sensible thing and took it to Uclés, who was counting biscuit.

Maese Benito. The cinnamon goes down the wind. So do the ginger and the clove, and so do those flowers. Is there anything whose smell goes to windward?

The old man finished the cask he was on.

Yes, he said.

What?

Uclés took the bags from him and tied their necks. He had been a man-at-arms once, in the household of the Master of Santiago, and he had by ear the long poem the Master's son made when the old man died, as half of Castile had it. He said a piece of it now, shutting the lid.

> *Where are the high-born dames, and where*
> *Their gay attire, and jewelled hair,*
> *And odors sweet?*
>
> *— Jorge Manrique, Coplas, tr. H. W. Longfellow*

I saw ladies of that kind when I was a page, he said. *You could smell them the length of a hall, if you stood on the right side of the door. They are dead, and so is their rosewater.*

He turned the key.

Now. Say there is a man in some town, I don't care which town. Or a woman. This one kills nothing he has no need to kill. He takes nothing that has not been given him. He keeps out of other men's beds. He doesn't lie to you, and he doesn't drink himself stupid. And his hand is open. You ask him for a thing and

he is already reaching for it, and glad you asked. I tell you the name of that one goes out from that town to every quarter of the compass, up the wind and down it. Friars carry it. Muleteers carry it. When I was a boy in Uclés, forty leagues from any salt water, I knew the name of a ferryman on the Miño whom I never laid eyes on.

And he said the rest.

His signal deeds and prowess high
Demand no pompous eulogy.
Ye saw his deeds!
Why should their praise in verse be sung?
The name, that dwells on every tongue,
No minstrel needs.

— Jorge Manrique, Coplas, tr. H. W. Longfellow

That was made about the Master. I don't say the Master was the man I am telling you of. He killed more people than I could count. But the verse is right about how such a name travels, whoever has it.

I never smelled one, Antón said.

You will know it when you do.

The men who had been near enough to hear went on sitting where they were for some time. The smell of the cape came and went over the rail until the watch was changed.

III. The Reef

Off the north coast of the island they named Española · Christmas night

On the night before Christmas the sea lay like water in a bowl. The Admiral had not slept in two days, and at eleven he went below. The sailor at the tiller wanted his sleep as well. The Admiral had forbidden it the whole voyage, calm or blow, but the man gave the tiller to a boy and lay down. The boy was Antón.

At midnight the current set the ship onto a bank, so gently that nobody aboard felt it. Antón felt the rudder take the ground and heard

the water rushing, and he cried out. It was too late then. The master and his men took the boat and rowed for the caravel that lay half a league off. The mast was cut away to lighten her. She fell over on her side all the same, and her seams opened.

By the middle of the morning Antón was sitting on the sand by himself. Nobody had beaten him yet. He supposed that was coming, or a rope, and he sat apart because no man in the company would sit by him.

The king of that coast had his town a league and a half away. When he was told, he wept, and he sent every person he had and every large canoe. They went out to the wreck and came back, and went out, and in a few hours they had landed everything between her decks: the casks, the biscuit, the iron shot, the trade beads, the box. The king and his brothers worked among them. Each thing as it came ashore was carried to a place by the houses and set down there, and nothing went into the trees. The lace-point off a seaman's sleeve dropped into a canoe, and the man in the stern picked it up and brought it over the sand and put it into the seaman's hand. The Admiral said afterward that there was not so much as a needle missing, and that no such watch could have been kept in any part of Castile.

Now and again the king sent one of his kinsmen, weeping, to tell the Admiral not to grieve, for he would give him all he had. One of these, an old man, on his way back along the beach, stopped where the boy sat. He set down beside him a cake of their bread and a gourd of water, and went on to the canoes.

Uclés came and sat down by Antón on the other side. All night there had been a light air off the land. With the sun it had gone round, and it was blowing in from the sea by then, straight onto the beach and into their faces, with nothing on it but salt. The canoes were still going out through it and coming back.

You asked me, Uclés said.

IV. The Name

Palos and Moguer · 1493 and after

THIRTY-NINE MEN WERE LEFT ON THAT SHORE, IN A FORT BUILT out of the ship's timbers, with bread for a year. Uclés asked to be one of them. His knees would not carry him over another ocean, he said, and stores want a steward. Before the caravel sailed he untied the cinnamon bag and gave Antón one stick of the bark.

There was a wind for Spain after all. It lay far to the north and had to be gone up and looked for, and it nearly drowned them in February. On the way the Admiral wrote a letter. By April the letter was printed at Barcelona. By May it had been put into Latin at Rome, and before the year was out it was printed again at Basel and Paris and Antwerp, and a man in Italy had turned it into verse. In every one of those tongues it carried a sentence that Antón could have told them himself.

Of anything they have, if it be asked for, they never say no, but do rather invite the person to accept it, and show as much lovingness as though they would give their hearts.

So the name of that king's people went up every wind in Christendom, to towns that had never smelled a clove. The letter said another thing a little farther down, which was how few armed men it would take to master the whole of that land. That traveled on the same sheet.

In September seventeen ships went down the east wind from Cádiz. They found the fort burned to the ground and the thirty-nine dead, and they heard what some of the thirty-nine had done among the women of that country before they died. Eleven bodies were shown to them with the grass already grown over. Nobody could tell Antón afterward whether the steward was one of the eleven. As for the people who had emptied the ship and lost not a needle, the seventeen ships were the beginning of what was done to them, and before Antón was an old man there was hardly a town of theirs left on the island. A friar who had been a boy in Seville the week the Admiral passed through wrote about them for fifty years, and said what the letter had said.

Antón did not go west again. He kept the stick of cinnamon in the lining of his cap. By the time he was thirty it had no more smell than kindling, and he kept it there all the same.

In his age he sat most afternoons on the river wall at Moguer, when the wind comes in over the bar from the west. He would turn his face into it. People took him to be watching for a sail. He told them there was nothing on that wind a man could smell, and he sat in it until the light went.

Background

The verses

> *The scent of flowers does not travel against the wind, nor (that of) sandal-wood, or of Tagara and Mallika flowers; but the odour of good people travels even against the wind; a good man pervades every place.*
>
> Dhammapada 54, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Sandal-wood or Tagara, a lotus-flower, or a Vassiki, among these sorts of perfumes, the perfume of virtue is unsurpassed.*
>
> Dhammapada 55, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Ānanda, the Buddha's attendant, sits one evening thinking about the three finest perfumes, those of sandalwood, of roots and of flowers. Each of them travels only with the wind. He wonders whether any scent goes against it, decides not to settle the question alone, and asks the Teacher. The Buddha answers that there is one: where a man or woman takes refuge, refrains from killing, stealing, sexual wrongdoing, lying and drink, and is open-handed, glad to give and attentive to those who ask, that person's praise is spoken in every direction by ascetics, brahmins and gods. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda.

The Santa María, off Hispaniola

The first voyage, 1492–93

The voyage of 1492 was a commercial venture. The agreement signed that April promised Columbus a tenth of the pearls, precious stones, gold, silver and spices he might find, and his journal records him showing the islanders "specimens of cinnamon and pepper he had brought from Castile." The steady northeast trade wind that carried the three ships west frightened their crews. The entry for 22 September reads: "This contrary wind was very necessary for me, because my people were much excited at the thought that in these seas no wind ever blew in the direction of Spain." On 19 October, anchored off the cape he named Cabo Hermoso, Columbus wrote that he "found the smell of the trees and flowers so delicious that it seemed the pleasantest thing in the world." The sailors' evening *Salve*, sung "in their way," is in the journal too. The half-hour glass turned by the ship's boys, with a verse sung at each turn, is known from later Spanish accounts. Antón, Uclés and the box are invented.

On Christmas night the *Santa María* grounded off the north coast of Hispaniola with the tiller in the hands of a ship's boy. The Taíno cacique Guacanagarí sent his people in canoes to unload her, and Columbus wrote that "there was not even a needle missing" and that "they are a loving people, without covetousness." Thirty-nine men stayed behind at La Navidad. The sentence about people who "never say no" is from Columbus's letter of February 1493, printed at Barcelona in April and, in Latin, at Rome, Basel, Paris and Antwerp within the year; the same letter boasts that the men left at the fort "are alone sufficient to destroy all that land." The second fleet of seventeen ships found the fort burned and the garrison dead; its physician, Dr. Chanca, saw eleven bodies and heard that the Spaniards had taken women. Within two generations the Taíno of Hispaniola had been reduced to a remnant, though their descendants live in the Caribbean still. The friar is Bartolomé de las Casas. Jorge Manrique wrote his *Coplas* on the death of his father Rodrigo, Master of the Order of Santiago, in 1476; Longfellow's English version appeared in 1833. Quotations from

the journal and letter follow the translations in *The Northmen, Columbus and Cabot* (1906).

After the story of the elder Ānanda's question from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 54 and 55). The original. Verses from the *Coplas* of Jorge Manrique in the translation of Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1833). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

4.10

Slippery Dumplings

> *A good name is better than precious ointments: and the day of death than the day of one's birth.*
> *— Ecclesiastes 7:2, Douay-Rheims*

This is how they tell it, on the East Side.

I. The Rag Bin

Wilmington, Delaware · 1968–2019

Walt Hollingsworth came down out of Chateau Country in the summer of 1968, while the National Guard was still parked on the East Side with bayonets on their rifles, and walked into St. Martin de Porres House on a Tuesday morning in a suit his mother had bought him at Wanamaker's. He was twenty-eight. His great-grandfather had made black powder on the Brandywine, and his grandfather had made money out of everything that came after the powder, and Walt had an office on the ninth floor downtown with his name on the door. He had come to drop off a check. A tall Black man in a white apron took the check, folded it, put it in the apron pocket, and handed him a ladle.

That was Doc. Dr. Clement Pinder had grown up six blocks from the house, been baptized at St. Joseph's on French Street, and gone from Howard High School to Lincoln University and a doctorate in chemistry. Since 1962 he had worked in a stone laboratory at the DuPont Experimental Station on the Brandywine, one of a handful of Black chemists in the place. He came to the house every morning at five to make the coffee before he drove to work. He could tell you what was burning three blocks away and what it had been painted with. He did not say much. Walt stood

next to him at the soup pot for the rest of that summer, and in the fall he did not go back to the ninth floor.

Fifty years later he was still there. He slept on a cot in the basement by the boiler. He had never bought a piece of clothing since 1968. He wore what came out of the rag bin, the bag of donations too far gone to give away that went once a month to a man who bought rags by the pound, and he wore it until it fell off him. He had gone to federal prison three times for walking onto the grounds of weapons plants and praying there. He ate once a day, standing up, after the line was fed. Every Lent he went alone for seven days to a cabin in the woods behind a Trappist abbey in the Virginia hills and spoke to no one. He came back thinner and said nothing about it.

The volunteers loved him the way people love a thing they would not want to be. The students from the Catholic girls' schools who came for their service hours, the church ladies from Greenville and Centreville with their trays of baked ziti, the young Workers who came for a year and stayed for two: all of them wanted, more than anything, to feed Walt. He would not let them. He let the guests feed him. If a man in the line broke a pack of crackers in half and held out the half, Walt took it, thanked him, and ate it right there. That was what the guests knew about Walt, and why some of them would have walked into the river for him.

Doc said Walt had a nose for poor people the way a dog has a nose for a rabbit, and that it was the only thing he had ever taught him that took.

II. Five Hundred Plates

The second Saturday of Lent · March 2019

That spring the company his grandfather had worked for was being cut in three. Two years before, it had married Dow Chemical; now the lawyers were taking the marriage apart into three new companies with three new names, and the newspaper was full of who would go where. Walt did not read the newspaper. He came back from Virginia on a Friday night on the Amtrak with his seven days behind him, and on

Saturday morning he put on a rag-bin coat with one toggle left and walked out the door of the house with his bowl.

The bowl was white enamel with a blue rim, chipped black in three places, and it was the one thing he owned that he had chosen. He meant to go out on the East Side, street by street, the way he did the first morning after every retreat, and take whatever the poorest door he came to would give him.

He did not get to the corner. It was a Saturday in Lent, and the volunteers were arriving: the girls from the Catholic schools in their plaid skirts and pink running shoes, the ladies from Greenville, two vans of college students from Newark. Word had gone around that Walt was back from his seven days, and every one of them had brought him something. They came at him down the sidewalk with foil pans and Tupperware and paper plates under plastic wrap, banana bread, a pot of chili, an egg-salad sandwich cut in triangles with the crusts off. There seemed to be hundreds of them.

Walt, eat something. Please. Do us the favor.

Go on in, Walt said. *The line's coming. I'm going to eat with the poor today.*

Walt, don't do this to us. Just a bite.

He knew them. He knew what they wanted, and it was not a bad thing to want, and it was not his to give. He told them no again. They kept coming, with the plates held out in front of them like offerings, and he stopped in the middle of the sidewalk.

You don't know your place, he said. *Go in.*

And he snapped his fingers, once, the way you would at a dog in the kitchen.

The girls in the pink shoes say they did not decide to go. They were simply inside, all of them, with their pans, standing in the dining room with their hearts going, and none of them could say afterward how they had got through the door. Out on the sidewalk Walt tucked the enamel bowl under his arm and went on toward the corner.

III. Chairs Caned

The East Side · the same morning

Out the Kennett Pike, in a stone house with nineteen rooms, Hollis Cosgrove had been listening. He had people at the house who told him things. He had known Walt since they were eight years old and sat two desks apart at a school in the hills where boys wore ties to breakfast. Cos was eighty. His grandfather's name was on a wing of the hospital and a gallery at the art museum, and he was by any measure the richest man Walt had ever refused.

He heard the volunteers had been sent in with their plates, and he laughed out loud at his breakfast table, and his wife Sue looked at him over her glasses.

Plates, Cos said. *Those children can't feed Walt. Nobody can feed Walt.* He sat a while. *I can.*

Walt went down the East Side looking for the poorest door. He had walked those blocks every morning for fifty years. He knew which windows had plywood in them and which had curtains, who was in the hospital and who was in jail and whose daughter was sending money home from Georgia. Halfway down a block of brick rowhouses below the hill, between two that had been boarded since the eighties, he came to a narrow storefront he did not remember. The window had been washed. A sign in the window, lettered by hand in house paint, said CHAIRS CANED · RUSH · SPLINT.

Through the glass he could see an old man bent nearly double over a chair frame turned upside down on a table, weaving cane through the holes of the seat rail strand by strand, and an old woman beside him with her hands in a washtub, soaking the next strands soft and drawing them out one by one and laying them in his palm. The man's hands were knotted like roots. The woman was missing teeth. Neither of them looked up.

Walt stood on the sidewalk and looked at them for a long time. Two people that old, working with their hands on a Saturday morning in March for the price of a chair seat. He did not think there could be any-

body in Wilmington poorer than that. If they give me a spoonful of anything, he thought, I'll take it, and it will be theirs to have given.

He went and stood at the door.

Inside, the old man said low, without lifting his head, *Sue. He's here. Don't look up. Keep working. Let him stand a minute.*

They let him stand. The cane went in and out of the holes. The water dripped from the old woman's hands. After a while the old man said, louder, *I believe there's somebody at the door. Go see.*

You go see, she said.

So the old man got up from the table by stages, one hand on the chair frame, and came out onto the step, and got down on his knees on the sidewalk in front of Walt with his forehead nearly to the concrete. Then he took hold of Walt's knees with both hands and wept. Then he sat back on his heels and squinted up.

Which one are you? He shaded his eyes. *My eyes are gone, I can't see a thing.* He looked a while longer and put his hand flat on his forehead. *Lord. It's Walt. It's been a long time since Walt came by this door.* He turned his head toward the shop. *Is there anything in the house?*

The old woman stood in the doorway wiping her hands on her apron, looking embarrassed, as if she had been caught with nothing on the stove. *There is,* she said.

Don't mind whether it's good or bad, the old man said, holding out his hands for the bowl. *Just do us the kindness.*

Walt gave him the enamel bowl. It made no difference to him whether it was a spoonful of rice or a heel of bread or the water off a pot of beans. He would take it and thank them.

IV. Slippery Dumplings

The same morning

THE OLD MAN TOOK THE BOWL INSIDE TO A HOT PLATE AT THE back of the shop where a dented pot sat on the coil. He lifted the lid and ladled, then came back out and put the bowl in Walt's two hands.

It was chicken and slippery dumplings, the way they make it downstate, the broth gold with fat and black with pepper, the dumplings rolled thin and cut in diamonds and gone soft and slick in the pot, and the chicken pulled off the bone in long pieces.

The smell went up off the bowl and out along the block. It went in at the boarded windows and the curtained ones. It went down to the train station, where people waiting for the 10:40 to Philadelphia lifted their heads from their phones, and up the hill to the courthouse, and across to the old DuPont Building, where the security guard at the desk put down his coffee. In the kitchen of the hotel on Rodney Square a cook stopped with a sauté pan in the air. At St. Martin de Porres House the line for lunch, which had been forming since eleven, went silent along its whole length, and the girls in the pink shoes came out onto the step to see what it was. On the Brandywine, people walking their dogs said afterward that the dogs had all sat down at once and pointed their noses south.

Walt stood on the sidewalk with the bowl warm between his hands and thought: this man is weak, and old, and has nothing, and this is not a poor man's dinner. This is the dinner of somebody who can have anything in the world brought to him. Who is this?

He looked at the old man, really looked, and the old man looked back. Under the knotted hands and the gone teeth Walt saw a boy two desks away in a school in the hills, with a necktie and a cowlick.

Cos, he said.

Hollis Cosgrove did not try to deny it.

You've done a hard thing, Walt said. *Do you know what you took? Mrs. Gaines on the next block would have given me a spoon of her lima beans this morning. Or Junior under the bridge, half his crackers. And then that would be theirs. It would be the thing they did today, that nobody could take off them. They could have stood up in front of God with it. You took that off them.*

Walt, Cos said, still on his knees on the sidewalk. *Is there anybody in this city poorer than me?*

You have nineteen rooms, Walt said. *You have a hospital with your name on it.*

Had. Let me tell you. Cos got up slowly, by stages, and the knots in his hands were real. *I did what I did, all my life, and before you were born my grandfather did it. And then in the last few years three men came to this town. Three. A credit-card man, a pharmaceutical man and a man with a fund. They came up fast and they came up together, and they are younger than my son. When those three walk into a room at the Hotel du Pont and say let's have a party, I get my coat and go home. My name came off the theater last year; theirs went up on the new wing. Their light comes over mine, Walt. Mine doesn't come over theirs. I have nineteen rooms and nobody in them. Who's poorer than that?*

Walt looked at him a long time.

If that's so, he said, *then don't trick me again.*

But did it count? Cos said. *What I did just now. Lying to you. Did it count for anything?*

It counted, Cos.

Then I'd better keep at it, hadn't I, Cos said. *It's my job now.*

He and Sue bowed to Walt on the sidewalk, and then they walked once all the way around him, slowly, keeping him on their right, the way you would walk around something in a church. And then they went up.

That is the part people on the block argue about. There are four of them who will swear to it, and one of them is Mrs. Gaines, who was at her window: the two old people rose off the sidewalk like the air had decided to carry them, up past the boarded windows and the gutters and the roofline, and went off over the rooftops toward the Brandywine, getting smaller and younger as they went. And from up there Cos shouted, three times, so loud that it came down on the whole city like weather:

Oh, the giving! The best gift there is, and it's set down safe in Walt's bowl!

When Walt looked back at the storefront there was nothing there but a lot full of last year's weeds and, in the middle of it, a chair frame with half a seat of cane.

V. The Good Odour

St. Martin de Porres House · noon

Doc was eighty-eight and still came at five to make the coffee, though now one of the young Workers drove him. At noon he was sitting on a stool by the urns with his cane between his knees, and he lifted his head and turned it toward the window before the smell had reached the room.

Listen, he said. *That's Hollis Cosgrove. Up over the Brandywine, hollering.*

Nobody else in the kitchen heard a thing. A girl in pink running shoes, the one who had brought the egg-salad sandwich with the crusts cut off, came and stood by his stool.

What's he hollering about?

He fed Walt, Doc said. *He tricked him into it, and now he's flying around the sky bragging.*

How did he know to feed Walt? she said. She was close to tears. *We all tried.*

Doc laughed, a dry small laugh. *Everybody wants to feed a man who eats like Walt eats. Lives on what he's handed. Keeps nobody but himself. Quiet. Watching every minute. Honey, the angels would trade places with that man if they could. A rich man would put on rags to feed him. One just did.*

Then the smell came in through the window. The kitchen went still, and everybody turned toward it, the cooks and the girls and the men in the line, the way people turn toward music.

Doc closed his eyes and took a long breath of it, all the way down.

Thirty-four years I smelled things for that company, he said. *There's nothing you can put in a bottle I can't tell you what's in it. Sandalwood. Musk. Rose. The ones they make in the lab and the ones they dig out of a tree. I can tell you what's in that bowl down the street, too. Chicken, celery, black pepper, lard in the dumplings.* He opened his eyes. *None of it gets higher than the ceiling. There's only one smell I know of that goes up all the way, and it's not in that bowl. It's on Walt.*

He tapped his cane twice on the floor, the way he did when he was going to say something from St. Joseph's, from the years when the priest still read it to them in that old English.

> *Now thanks be to God, who always maketh us to triumph in Christ Jesus and manifesteth the odour of his knowledge by us in every place. For we are the good odour of Christ unto God, in them that are saved and in them that perish.*
>
> *— 2 Corinthians 2:14–15, Douay-Rheims*

Down the street Walt sat on the curb in front of the empty lot and ate the dumplings, every one, slowly, because they had been given. Then he went back to the house and stood at the end of the line until it was fed.

• • •

The next morning he went out again with the bowl washed. He went to Mrs. Gaines's door on the next block. She looked at him a while through the screen as if she were deciding something, then went back into her kitchen and came out with the pot she had cooked the night before.

She gave him four lima beans and a spoon of their juice. He ate them standing on her step, in the cold, with his coat open, and thanked her, and she watched him to the last bean.

Background

The verse

> *Mean is the scent that comes from Tagara and sandal-wood;--the perfume of those who possess virtue rises up to the gods as the highest.*
>
> Dhammapada 56, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Mahā Kassapa, foremost of the Buddha's disciples in ascetic practice, rises from seven days of meditative absorption and goes on his alms round in Rājagaha, meaning to accept food only from the poor, so that they may gain the merit of giving. Five hundred celestial nymphs wait on the road with alms; he refuses them, and when they persist he snaps his fingers and they flee. Sakka, king of

the gods, then disguises himself and his wife Sujā as a decrepit old weaver and his wife spinning thread in a poor lane, and when the elder stops at their door Sakka fills his bowl with food whose fragrance fills the whole city. The elder recognizes him and rebukes him for robbing the poor of their chance. Sakka answers that no one is poorer than he, because three newly arisen gods outshine him, and asks whether his deceitful gift still earned merit. Told that it did, he circles the elder, rises into the air, and cries out three times in praise of the gift. The Buddha hears him and says that gods and humans alike love one who lives as Kassapa does. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa and Sakka.

Wilmington, Delaware

Wilmington, Delaware, 1968–2019

Wilmington grew up around the du Pont family's black-powder mills on the Brandywine, founded in 1802 and now the Hagley Museum. The company built its research laboratory, the Experimental Station, on the same creek; nylon, Kevlar and Tyvek came out of it. In August 2017 DuPont merged with Dow Chemical as DowDuPont, and in 2019 the combined company was split into three: Dow, Corteva and a new DuPont. After the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr. in April 1968, the Wilmington riot was followed by a National Guard occupation that lasted the rest of the year, reportedly the longest military occupation of an American city since the Civil War. The city's historic Black Catholic parish is St. Joseph's on French Street. St. Martin de Porres House, the Cosgroves, Walt, Doc and Mrs. Gaines are invented.

The Catholic Worker movement, founded by Dorothy Day and Peter Maurin in New York in 1933, runs houses of hospitality and farms where volunteers live in voluntary poverty among the people they serve; its paper, The Catholic Worker, was first sold for a penny in Union Square. Many Workers have gone to prison for nonviolent protest at weapons sites. Chicken and slippery dumplings, flat rolled dumplings cut in diamonds and cooked in the broth, is a staple of Delaware kitchens, from the poultry country downstate to church suppers in the city. Doc's scripture is the

Douay-Rheims Bible in Bishop Challoner's revision, the English Bible of American Catholics for most of two centuries.

After the story of the alms given to the Elder Mahā Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 56). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

4.11

The Yellow Fiddle

> *But darkness shall not be dark to thee, and night shall be light as day.*
> *— Psalm 138:12 (Douay-Rheims)*

The way I heard it told, up Sylamore Creek.

I. The Warm Rock

Sylamore Creek, Stone County, Arkansas · 1946

The monks came over from Kentucky in April of 1946, twenty-two of them in two borrowed trucks, to a worn-out hill farm on Sylamore Creek that a widow in Little Rock had left to the Church. The abbey in Kentucky was full past bursting with men home from the war, and the abbot was sending them out wherever somebody gave him land. There was a dogtrot house on the place, and a barn with a tin roof, and a spring, and about forty acres that would grow anything but money. They put up wallboard cells four feet wide in the hayloft and slept there in their habits on straw ticks. They rose at two in the morning for the Night Office. They did not speak.

Brother Isidore had been born four miles up the same creek in 1884, as Lafe Sutterfield. He had farmed, and fiddled some when he was young, and buried a wife, and in 1926 he had gone to Kentucky and asked to be let in as a lay brother, and they had let him. Twenty years he had worn the brown habit and the beard and milked other people's cows. When the abbot looked for a man who knew the Arkansas hills, Isidore was the one, and so he came home. At the new place he was the cowman, because he knew cows, and the infirmarian, because there was nobody else.

Brother Paschal was the youngest of the choir novices, in white. His name in the world had been Francis Kemper. His father was a surgeon on Lafayette Square in St. Louis, and the Jesuits had taught him, and he had gone from Saint Louis University into the Marines and landed on Guadalcanal in August of 1942 with the First Division. He came home the next year weighing a hundred and eighteen pounds, with the malaria in his blood. He was twenty-six. He had a long, quiet face and very good manners, and the lay brothers liked him, which the lay brothers did not always do with the young men from the cities.

In the afternoon work that first summer he was sent to cut cedar off the bluff pasture above the creek. When the bell rang for the break, the others sat down in the shade. Paschal went out on a shelf of grey limestone at the edge of the bluff, where the sun lay all day, and sat with his hands in his sleeves, and went still.

Isidore saw it once from the fence row. He had seen men pray all his life, at brush arbors and at the abbey, men with their lips going and men with their eyes squeezed shut. This was not like that. It was like the boy had gone down a well and pulled the lid over. The fence lizards that lived in the cracks of the bluff came out one at a time onto the warm rock around him, the way they will when nothing is moving, and one of them climbed his sleeve and sat on the back of his hand with its sides going in and out, and he did not stir, and it did not leave.

After that the lay brothers had a sign for him among themselves, a flat hand with the fingers flickering. The Lizard. They did not mean any harm by it.

II. Chills and Fever

The infirmary · June 1946 to March 1947

The first time it came back on him was in June. Isidore found him at Vespers holding the edge of the choir stall with both hands, his teeth going like a sewing machine, and walked him across the yard to the dogtrot house, where the infirmary was two rooms and a washstand. Isidore knew the look of it. Every child on Sylamore Creek in his day had

HAD THE CHILLS AND FEVER, EVERY OTHER SUMMER, AND HIS own mother had kept a quinine bottle on the shelf by the salt. First the shaking, so hard the cot walked on the floor. Then the fever, a hundred and four, a hundred and five, and the boy talking to somebody named Gunny who was not there. Then the sweat, and the sheets wringing wet, and then nothing, a day or two of weakness like a wrung rag, and then it came again.

The doctor from Mountain View came out in his Ford and gave atabrine, which turned Paschal's skin yellow as a squash. In two weeks he was back in choir. In three he was back on the rock.

But it was not the same, and he told Isidore so, because the infirmarian could speak to the sick and the sick could answer him. Isidore was changing the bed.

It goes, Brother. When the fever comes, it goes. I sit out there and it isn't there.

It'll come back.

It did come back. It took a month.

The second time was in August, and the third at the end of September, when the sumac was red on the bluffs. Each time Isidore sat up with him, and each time it went the same way: the shaking, the fever, the sweat, the weakness, the slow walk back to choir, and then a long while on the rock waiting, like a man at a spring that has stopped, and then one afternoon the lizards coming out again. The fourth time was at Christmas. The fifth was in January, in the snow. By then the doctor had stopped saying the boy would grow out of it. Some of them did, he said, and some of them had it ten and twelve times. There was nothing in his bag to stop it coming back.

After the fifth time Paschal lay in the infirmary looking at the ceiling for most of a week, and one night when the lamp was down he said, *What happens to a man who keeps falling back? Six times, seven times. You'd think God would get tired of fetching him.*

Isidore was sitting in the chair by the stove. He had been asleep, or nearly.

That's the fever talking, he said. *I've had it. It lies to you. It told me once my wife was in the yard calling me.*

I'm a burden on this house.

You're the least burden in it. You ought to see Brother Alberic eat.

Paschal did not laugh, and Isidore did not like that he did not. The next morning he went to Father Prior, which a lay brother did not do lightly, and stood in the door of the little office with his cap in his hands and said what he had heard. The prior was a big, slow Belgian who had been at the Kentucky house since before the first war. He listened, and wrote to the doctor, and wrote to the boy's mother in St. Louis, and moved Paschal out of the hayloft into the room off the infirmary, where Isidore could hear him in the night through the board wall. Isidore put his own straw tick on the floor across the door of the next room. For three weeks he did not sleep more than a few hours together, and he did not mind. He had sat up with cows.

The sixth time was in February. When it was over, Paschal went back out to the rock in his coat, in the cold, and sat a long time, and came back and did not say anything. Isidore watched his face and did not like what he saw, and could not have said what it was.

Then the seventh time came, in March, and it was short and light, and when it had passed Paschal got up and ate his bread and went out to the bluff in the first warm sun of the year, and came back with his face changed.

It came, he told Isidore. *Right away this time. It was all there.*

Isidore was glad, and believed him, and that night for the first time in weeks he went back up to the brothers' dormitory and slept the whole way to the bell.

III. The Barn

Before day · March 1947

THE LAY BROTHERS MILKED AT HALF PAST THREE, AFTER THEIR own prayers, while the choir monks were still in the Night Office. It was raining. Isidore had the lantern hung on the nail and his head in the

FLANK OF A RED COW WHEN THE COWS DOWN THE LINE ALL stood up at once in their stanchions and turned their heads the other way.

There was a man in the barn door. Isidore had not heard a car on the road or a step in the yard. The man wore a good grey overcoat and a hat, and the rain had not touched either one, and the barn cat had gone flat to the floor under the feed box and stayed there.

You're the old man that sits up with him, the man said. *The Marine. Kemper. He means to die this morning. You'd better go and stop him. He won't listen to a word from me.*

He said it in a reasonable voice, the way a neighbor tells you your gate is open. Isidore had grown up on this creek, where people knew certain things and did not say them to outsiders, and he looked at the man's dry hat and the cows' turned heads and he knew who was standing in the door.

You don't care one way or another if he lives, Isidore said. *You want to know where he goes.*

The man smiled at him.

He's not yours, Isidore said, and knocked over the milk getting up, and went past him out into the rain.

He ran. He was sixty-two years old and had not run since the year his wife died. He crossed the yard in the dark with his habit gathered up in his fists, went through the dogtrot to the infirmary door, and it was already over. Brother Paschal had taken his own life.

Isidore knelt down on the floor. He said the prayers for the dying, though it was past the time for them, because he could not think what else to say, and he said them all the way through. Then he went and rang the bell at the wrong hour, and kept ringing it, until the prior came across the yard with the oils.

• • •

In those years the law of the Church said that a man who killed himself deliberately was not to have Christian burial. The prior sat a long time in his office with the book. Then he came out and said, by signs and then in

words, so that there would be no mistake, that Brother Paschal had been very sick for a long while and had not been himself, and that he would be buried with his brothers.

They buried him on the slope above the creek the next afternoon, the way they bury their own, in his white cowl, with no coffin, his hood drawn over his face, the brothers taking turns with the shovels. His mother came down from St. Louis on the train to Batesville and a neighbor drove her out in a truck. She was a small woman in a black coat, and she stood at the grave without crying and then afterward could not stop. Isidore was not allowed to speak to her, and he did anyway, out by the truck.

He was sick, ma'am. It was the sickness. He was as good a boy as I ever knew.

She held on to his sleeve. *Did he say anything?*

Isidore told her the truth, which was that he had been asleep upstairs, and had thought the boy was better. She did not let go of his sleeve for a long time.

IV. The Smoke

The week after

Bud Treat, hauling cedar posts on the Mountain View road on the Monday, saw a smoke go up the Sylamore valley against the wind with no fire under it. He told it at the store. It was a dark smoke, he said, like a brush pile of green cedar, and it went along the bluffs low and slow, and into the mouths of the little hollows one after another, and came back out of each one, and went on. Mrs. Lackey saw it go along her fence row and over her spring box and come back. Two of the novices saw it from the woodpile on the Tuesday. It went down to the creek and along the gravel bar and turned in the water like a dog casting for a scent, and came up the slope through the burying ground and stood a while there over the new dirt, and went on up into the cedars on the bluff.

Isidore was splitting kindling. The novices did not speak, but one of them caught his sleeve and pointed.

He stood and watched it a long time with the hatchet in his hand. It went out along the limestone shelf at the top of the bluff where the sun lay, and turned there, this way and that, and went down into the cracks, and came up.

He was allowed to speak to the novices for their instruction, and he decided this was instruction.

That's the one that came to the barn, he said. *He's hunting.*

Hunting what? said the younger one, forgetting.

Brother Paschal. Where he's gone. He's been through the burying ground and the creek and Mrs. Lackey's springhouse, and now he's up on the rock.

The smoke went down into the hayloft through the gap under the eaves, where the cells were, and came out the other end, and went on east.

Will he find him?

No, Isidore said, and went back to the kindling.

V. The Fiddle

The county road · Easter week

In Easter week Isidore was setting a post where the abbey lane meets the county road, because the cows had been out. It was a fine afternoon with the redbud out along the ridges. He heard the fiddle a good while before he saw the man.

He knew most of the tunes in Stone County and had played half of them, before he went to Kentucky, at dances his mother prayed against, and he did not know this one. It was quick and sweet and it went down into the low notes like water going over a lip of rock, and the cows in the near pasture all lifted their heads. Then the man came walking up the county road playing it. He was young, and handsome as a picture, in a suit the color of new butter, and the fiddle under his chin was yellow. Not varnished yellow. The wood itself was yellow all through, the bright hard yellow of hedge apple, bois d'arc, which the old people said was too hard to make anything of but fence posts and bows.

He stopped across the post hole from Isidore and took the fiddle down from his chin. His face had gone sad and puzzled, like a child's that has lost something in the grass.

Old man, he said. *I've been all over. I've been up every hollow on this creek and down the White River to Batesville, and over the ridges, and up the sky as far as a man can get and down the other way as far as it goes. I've been in the graveyard and in the creek and in the loft and in the rock. I looked everywhere he ever set his foot and everywhere he didn't. Where has he gone?*

Isidore leaned on the post-hole digger. He said it the way the Catholic book has it, though he had heard it first another way, as a boy, at a brush arbor on Turkey Creek.

> *Whither shall I go from thy spirit? or whither shall I flee from thy face? If I ascend into heaven, thou art there: if I descend into hell, thou art present. If I take my wings early in the morning, and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea: Even there also shall thy hand lead me: and thy right hand shall hold me.*
>
> *— Psalm 138:7–10 (Douay-Rheims)*

Everyplace you looked, Isidore said, *somebody was there before you.*

The young man stood there in the road. His face went slack, the way a face does when there is no more use in trying. His arms came down, and the fiddle slid out of them into the grass by the ditch, and the bow after it.

Isidore bent to pick them up, because he could not stand to see a fiddle lie in the wet. When he straightened up the road was empty both ways, as far as the bend, and there was no dust on it.

What he had in his hands was a split limb of hedge apple about as long as his arm, and a switch, and that was all. He used the limb to prop the gate.

VI. The Lantern

Sylamore Creek · 1947 and after

That evening, after Compline, the two novices who had seen the smoke came and stood by the woodpile where Isidore was sitting, and waited with their hands in their sleeves. He knew what they wanted. They wanted to know what he knew, and he did not know very much. He knew that the boy had been sick and had suffered, and that the sickness had told him lies, and that the old man had not been awake when he was needed, and would carry that. He knew who had come to the barn door, and he knew that a hundred like him could hunt this creek until the Judgment and not find what they were looking for. He said it to them as Saint Paul says it, because Saint Paul says it better.

> *For I am sure that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, nor might, Nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.*
>
> *— Romans 8:38–39 (Douay-Rheims)*

The younger novice was crying. Isidore let him, and after a while sent them both to bed.

• • •

The government spray men came through the county that summer with their hand pumps and sprayed DDT on the inside walls of the houses, the dogtrot house too, and in a few years there was hardly any chills and fever left in Arkansas. The abbey did not last. It was too poor and too far from anything, and in 1953 the monks went back to Kentucky and left the land to the cedars. They took Brother Paschal with them, in a pine box this time, and he lies at the big house now among the others, under the same plain cross as all of them.

Isidore lived to be ninety and was infirmarian until the last two years of it. The young monks at the Kentucky house, where there were always

sick, said that he had one rule he would not bend for any abbot, and that was that no brother with a fever would lie alone at night. When they were sick he came in with a straw tick over his shoulder and a lantern, and put the tick down across the door, and sat up in the chair by the bed with a basin of cool water on his knees, an old man in brown with a white beard, the lantern turned down low so it would not wake them, as long as it took.

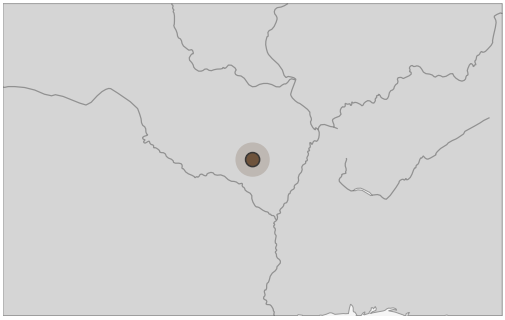
Background

This story involves a suicide. If you are thinking about suicide, or worried about someone, help is available now. In the United States, call or text 988 to reach the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline; elsewhere, your local emergency number or a crisis line can help. Talking to someone does help.

The verse

> *Of the people who possess these virtues, who live without thoughtlessness, and who are emancipated through true knowledge, Mara, the tempter, never finds the way.*
>
> Dhammapada 57, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Godhika lives on the Black Rock at Isigili, near Rājagaha. A long illness makes him fall away from deep meditation six times; on the seventh, fearing for his future, he takes his own life. Māra, the tempter, comes to the Buddha in disguise and urges him to stop the monk, but only because he wants to keep Godhika inside his own realm, and the Buddha recognizes him. Afterward Māra searches every direction for Godhika's consciousness as a column of smoke and a mass of darkness, then comes as a young man with a yellow lute of vilva wood to ask where Godhika has gone. The Buddha says he has gone beyond Māra's reach, and Māra drops his lute and vanishes. Read the full commentary story (it follows Saṃyutta Nikāya 4.23 almost word for word), or about Māra. In the Buddhist tradition, Godhika's case is an exception that the texts treat with great care; neither the commentary nor this retelling holds it up as an example. Here the story's center is the searcher who cannot find him, and the old brother who stays with the sick.



Sylamore Creek, Stone County, Arkansas

The Arkansas Ozarks, 1946-47

After the Second World War, the Trappist abbey of Our Lady of Gethsemani in Kentucky filled with so many new monks, many of them veterans, that it sent out foundations across the country, among them Conyers, Georgia (1944), Huntsville, Utah (1947) and Mepkin, South Carolina (1949). The Sylamore Creek foundation in this story is invented. The details of Trappist life are drawn from accounts of the time: rising at two in the morning, silence kept with a sign language, choir monks in white and lay brothers in brown with beards, and burial in the habit without a coffin. Under the 1917 Code of Canon Law, those who deliberately took their own lives were to be denied church burial; superiors and pastors often judged that illness had taken away the person's freedom, and the current Code no longer contains the rule.

Malaria was a fact of life in Arkansas well into the twentieth century. According to the Encyclopedia of Arkansas, the state reported more malaria deaths than any other through most of the 1920s and 1930s, and a federal campaign sprayed hundreds of thousands of homes with DDT between 1947 and 1953. In the Pacific, the Guadalcanal campaign left many thousands of American servicemen with malaria; relapsing vivax malaria brought many of them back to fever again and again, ten relapses being not unusual, and a drug that could clear the dormant parasite was not yet in general use. Ozark folk belief long called the fiddle the devil's instrument, and in Southern folklore the devil is a stranger you meet on the road carrying a fiddle of his own.

After the story of the elder Godhika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 57). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

4.12

Pond Lilies

> *The people that walked in darkness have seen a great light.*
> *— Isaiah 9:2*

So it was told to me, by the Mashpee River.

I. The Summerland

Mashpee, Massachusetts · summer 1878

Isaac Wicket and Moses Freeman had been friends since they were boys spearing eels through the ice on Wakeby Pond, and by the time they were fifty they were the two most comfortable men in Mashpee. Isaac had cranberry bog on the Santuit side and an oyster grant in Popponesset Bay. Moses had bog of his own and two hundred acres of oak and pitch pine that he cut into cordwood and sent up to Boston by the schooner load. Their houses stood a quarter mile apart on the Falmouth road, and they had been in and out of each other's kitchens for forty years.

Isaac sat under Brother Simon at the Baptist meeting. Moses had sat there too, until his boy Charlie went over the side of a New Bedford whaling bark in a gale off the Azores, in the winter of 1876, and the sea did not give him back. Brother Simon had said at the memorial that the sea does not give back, that nobody could promise Moses otherwise and nobody should. Moses never went to meeting again.

In the summer of 1877 the Spiritualists had opened their great camp at Onset Bay, over the line in Wareham, with tents and a speakers' stand and a grove full of mediums who would talk with your dead for a dollar. By the next summer some of them had begun to travel. A company of five came down the Cape in a hired wagon: Dr. Elias Pratt, clairvoyant physi-

cian and test medium, and four younger men who sang and kept the cabinet and passed the hat. Moses Freeman took them in.

Dr. Pratt sat in Moses's front room in the dark and went stiff in his chair, and a voice came out of him that called itself Chief Thunder Cloud, and talked like a dime novel. Chief Thunder Cloud said the old sachems of Mashpee were gathered in the room. Chief Thunder Cloud said that Charlie Freeman was in the Summerland, where the sea could not reach him, and that he was well, and that he forgave his father. Moses wept like a child in the dark. In the morning he gave Dr. Pratt twenty dollars.

After that he could not leave Isaac alone. Wherever he found him, at the bog or the store or the landing, sitting or standing, he said it.

Isaac, what do you get from that blind man? What has he ever told you? He can't give you your dead. Come hear the Doctor. Bring him to your house. Feed him. It would mean something.

Isaac kept still about it for a good many days. He had known Moses all his life and he had carried Charlie Freeman on his shoulders. Then one hot morning on the landing, with Moses at him again in front of the oystermen, he set down his basket.

Moses. Every day, standing, sitting. All right. Tell me. What does your Doctor know?

Know? Moses lit up. *Isaac, there is nothing the spirits don't know. What's past and what's now and what's coming. Every thought in your head. They told me things about Charlie nobody living knew.*

Is that so.

It is so.

Then you've done me a wrong, Isaac said, *keeping it from me all this time. Go and ask the Doctor and his company to my house to supper. Saturday. Tell them I said so.*

The Doctor was very pleased. *Wicket,* he said. *The Baptist. Our work here is as good as done.*

II. Supper

Isaac Wicket's place · a Saturday in August

Isaac's house and his late father's house stood side by side with a long grassy space between them, and on Thursday and Friday Isaac and his three sons and two nephews dug a trench down the length of it, waist deep. They filled it with what you would expect: the slop of the hog pen, and fish heads and eel skins from the landing, and the black muck out of the bottom of an old ditch at the bog. Over the trench they set a long trestle table, and on the near side of it, five good chairs, with their front legs on the grass and their back legs resting on a rope stretched tight between two stakes. Over the chairs they spread Isaac's wife's best quilts, so nobody could see what the chairs were standing on.

Then he took every iron kettle and crock in both houses, scrubbed them out, and set them in a row behind the kitchen with cloths over their mouths. He smeared the outsides with chowder and dabbed them with succotash and Indian pudding, so that they looked like kettles that had been filled and stirred and slopped over. They were empty.

Early Saturday morning Moses came over to make sure of things.

Is there supper for them?

There's supper.

Where?

Here, said Isaac, and walked him along the row. *Chowder in these. Quahogs, these. Succotash. Eels. This is pudding. And there's chairs set for them, and the good quilts.*

That's handsome, Isaac, said Moses, and went home happy.

The Doctor's company came up the Falmouth road toward evening in their wagon, in black coats, very dusty. Isaac went out to the gate. He bowed to them, low, the way you would bow to a minister, and while he was bowing he said to them in his heart: *So you know what's past and what's now and what's coming. That is what my friend tells me. If you know it, don't come through this gate. There is not one bite of supper in my house for you. And if you don't know it, and come in anyway, you're going in the ditch.*

Out loud he said, *Come in, gentlemen.*

They came in. They saw the table and the quilts and went to sit, and Isaac's oldest boy called out, *Wait! Not yet, sirs, please.*

What is it?

It's the custom in this house. Each gentleman stands at his chair first, and then everybody sits down together at once. It's respect.

Isaac had thought of that himself. If one of them went into the ditch alone, he would holler, and the rest would never sit.

Of course, said Dr. Pratt, who had found it paid to do what people asked in their own houses. Each man stood at his chair. Isaac's nephews took hold of the corners of the quilts from behind.

All together now, sirs. Sit.

The nephews pulled the quilts away clean as they sat. The back legs of five chairs went down off the rope, and five clairvoyants went over backward with their boots in the air, head first into the ditch.

Isaac shut the gate. As fast as they crawled up out of the muck his sons laid into them with alder switches, and Isaac stood over the trench and called out to them, *So you know what's past and what's now and what's coming! So you know every thought in a man's head!* It went on longer than some of the neighbors who had come to watch could stand to see. A switch cuts. One of the nephews threw his down and walked off toward the road. At last Isaac said, *That'll do,* and opened the gate.

They ran. But in the afternoon Isaac had slathered the lane outside the gate with whitewash, thick, a bucket and a half of lime, and in the dew it was as slick as an eel's back. They went down, and got up, and went down, and the boys were waiting with the switches there too, until Isaac said, *That'll do for you,* and let them go.

They went the quarter mile up the Falmouth road in the dusk to Moses Freeman's door, filthy and bleeding and white to the knees with lime, crying out that they had been ruined. *You have ruined us! He has ruined us!*

III. The Trial Justice

Barnstable · August

Moses Freeman stood in his doorway and looked at them a long time. He had known Isaac Wicket for forty-five years and had never once in that time seen him do a cruel thing. Then he went white with anger, as white as their legs.

He's ruined me, he said. *They bowed to him. They came to his house as guests and he's beaten them with sticks. My teachers. The men who brought me my son.*

On Monday he drove to Barnstable and swore out a complaint for assault before the trial justice, and the justice sent a summons to Isaac Wicket.

Isaac came in his meeting coat and stood with his hat in his hands.

Your Honor, will you hear it before you fine me? Or fine me first?

I generally hear it first, Mr. Wicket.

Then hear it, and do what you think is right.

And he told it all from the beginning. Moses at him on the landing and the road and the store, standing and sitting, every day. What does your blind man know. The spirits know everything, the past, the present, the future, every thought in your head. The trench, the chairs, the kettles. He did not leave out the switches.

The trial justice was an old Barnstable lawyer who had sat through a good many lectures on table-rapping in his time and had believed none of them. He turned to Moses.

Is that the truth, Mr. Freeman?

It's the truth.

Then why in heaven's name did you take up with teachers who couldn't see as far as the supper table, and go around telling a Baptist they knew everything? You brought this down on your own head, sir, and on your own head it can stay. He dismissed the complaint and laid the costs of the court on Moses. And he told the constable to see Dr. Pratt and his company onto the cars at Sandwich, and if they were found in Barnstable County again they would answer for it as common fortune-tellers.

IV. The Bake

Mashpee · late August

For two weeks Moses would not speak to Isaac. He passed him on the road and looked at the trees. He went the long way around to the landing.

Then he thought it over, sitting by himself at night in the front room where Chief Thunder Cloud had talked. Sulking would get him nothing. What he wanted was for Isaac Wicket and Isaac's blind preacher to be laughed at in front of the whole town the way he had been laughed at, the way his teachers had been laughed at, crawling out of a ditch.

So he went to Isaac's gate. *Isaac.*

Moses.

Folks are saying we've fallen out. Kin and friends fall out, and then they get over it. Why won't you speak to me?

I don't speak because you don't, Isaac said. *But what's done is done. I'm not going to throw away forty years over it.* And after that they stood together on the landing again and sat together on the store steps the way they always had.

One day on the steps Isaac said, *Moses, what do you want with spirits? What did they ever give you but a bill at the court? Come back to meeting. Hear Brother Simon.*

It was exactly what Moses had been waiting for. It was like being scratched where he itched.

And what does your Brother Simon know?

Moses, don't talk like that. There's nothing the Lord keeps from him. He knows what's past and what's coming. He knows what's in a man before the man knows it.

Then you've done me a wrong, said Moses, *not telling me all this time. Ask him to my place. Saturday week. Him and the whole church. I'll put on a bake.*

• • •

Brother Simon Hosea was sixty-six that summer. He had gone whaling at fifteen out of New Bedford, like half the young men in Mashpee, and

come home at twenty-two without his eyes, and old Blind Joe Amos, who could say whole chapters of the Bible by heart, had taken him in hand and taught him to preach the same way, by ear, chapter by chapter, from his own mother's reading. He lived alone on the Cotuit road with a cat and a boy named Lemuel who led him where he needed to go.

Isaac went out to him that evening and told him about the bake.

Only, Brother Simon, I don't know if his heart's clean in it. I did a thing to his Spiritualists, a hard thing. He told it. *He may want to pay me back on you. Think it over. If it seems right to you, go. If it doesn't, don't.*

The old man sat in his chair facing the window he could not see out of, with the cat on his knees, for a long while.

People said afterward that he knew it all that night. That after Isaac had gone he told Lemuel what Moses Freeman meant to do, the pit and the fire and the cover over it, and what would come of it, the whole thing, and that Lemuel was twelve and did not believe a word. But Lemuel told it the same way for sixty years after.

We'll go, said Brother Simon. *For Moses's sake.*

• • •

Moses dug the pit between his house and his barn. He dug it deep, deeper than any clambake ever needed, and lined it with round stones off the beach at Popponesset, cartload after cartload, and filled it to the top with his own cordwood, oak and pitch pine, a cord and a half of it. On Friday evening he set it alight, and borrowed the bellows out of the smithy in Cotuit and worked them himself all night long, until the pile had burned down to a bed of coals and the stones underneath glowed red in the dark, and you could feel the heat of it from the kitchen steps.

Before light he laid poles across the pit, the thinnest poles he had, and over the poles marsh hay, and over the hay wet rockweed from the shore, a thick heap of it, so that it looked like any bake that had been laid down and covered and was steaming. Across the far side of it he set a chair, the best chair in his house, for the preacher. And from the near side to the chair he laid a walk of old lath, the kind that breaks if you look at it.

Behind his kitchen he set out every kettle he owned in a row, empty, with cloths over their mouths, smeared on the outsides with chowder. Exactly the way Isaac had.

On Saturday morning Isaac came over early. *Moses, is there dinner?*

Come see. Moses walked him down the row. *Chowder. Quahogs. Corn. Eels. Succotash. Pudding.*

That's handsome, Moses, said Isaac, and meant it.

V. The Lilies

Moses Freeman's place · the Saturday

By noon there was a crowd. Word goes around a small town. Half of Mashpee came, and people from Cotuit and Waquoit and even from Falmouth, white and Indian and colored, in wagons and on foot. Some came because Moses Freeman always set a good table. Some came because they had heard about the ditch, and the trial justice, and they knew Moses, and they wanted to see what a man like that would do to a blind preacher. And some came because Brother Simon was going to speak at a bake, outdoors, in the summer, and they wanted to hear it.

Brother Simon came up the road at noon on Lemuel's arm, with the whole Baptist church walking behind him in their Sabbath clothes, forty or fifty of them. Moses met them at his gate. He bowed to the preacher low, the way Isaac had bowed, and while he was bowing he said to him in his heart: *So you know what's past and what's now and what's coming, Brother Simon. So you know what's in a man before he knows it himself. That's what Isaac tells me. If you know it, don't come through this gate. There's no dinner for you. There's a pit of fire, and you're going in it in front of everybody.*

Out loud he took the old man's hand and said, *Brother Simon, welcome. Only there's a custom at a bake in this house. The guest of honor goes first, by himself, and takes the head chair. After he's sat down, the rest can come.*

He had thought of that himself. If they saw the blind man go through, none of the others would go near it, and the blind man would be in the fire alone.

All right, said Brother Simon, and let go of Lemuel's arm.

Moses led him by the hand along the side of the house to the edge of the rockweed, and the crowd came after and stood around the yard. The heat came up through the weed so that the air above it shook. Moses put the old man's boot on the end of the lath walk. Then he let go of his hand and stepped back, and back again, and stood off at a distance with the crowd.

Straight ahead, Brother Simon, he called. *Six steps.*

Brother Simon put his foot out over the pit.

The rockweed and the hay and the poles were simply gone, and the crowd saw the coals, a red floor of coals the size of a room. And up through the coals, pushing them apart the way a spring pushes up through sand, came lilies. Pond lilies, white, the kind that float on Wakeby and Mashpee pond on an August morning with their gold hearts open, only these were as wide as cartwheels, with pads under them as wide as wagon beds, rising on the heat as if it were water. The smell of them filled the whole yard, sweet and clean, over the smell of the fire.

Brother Simon set his foot down in the gold heart of the nearest one, and walked out across them in his Sabbath boots, one to the next, without hurrying, and sat down in Moses Freeman's best chair on the far side. And the whole Baptist church walked across after him, the old women holding their skirts, Lemuel at a run, and Isaac Wicket, and sat down on the grass around him.

Moses stood where he was. It was as if he had swallowed one of his own coals.

Then he went to Isaac, who was sitting on the grass by the preacher's chair, and knelt down in front of him.

Isaac. You have to help me.

What is it?

There's no dinner. There's nothing. Forty people and the whole town watching, and there's not a bite in the house.

What have you done, Moses?

He told him. The pit, the bellows, the lath, all of it. *I meant him to go in. I meant to shame him like you shamed them. And it's lilies, Isaac. Look at it. What do I do?*

This morning you walked me down a row of kettles, said Isaac. *You said this one is chowder and this one is quahogs and this one is pudding.*

I lied. They're empty.

Never mind that. Go and look in them.

Moses went around behind the kitchen and lifted the cloth off the first kettle, and it was full of chowder, hot, with the steam coming off it. The next was quahogs. The next was corn. Every kettle he had called by a name that morning was full of the thing he had called it, chowder and eels and succotash and corn and Indian pudding, to the brim, and when he got to the end of the row he stood with the last cloth in his hand and shook.

Then he carried them out himself, one by one, and served every soul in the yard with his own hands, the Baptists and the curious and the ones who had come to see the old man burn, and he did not sit down until everyone had eaten.

VI. Eyes

The same afternoon

When the eating was done Moses came and stood in front of the preacher's chair with his hat in his hands, the way men stood in Mashpee when they wanted the minister to return thanks.

Brother Simon turned his face toward the crowd. He could not see them, but he knew where they were, the way you know where the sea is at night.

A good many of you came out today to see a blind man fall in the fire, he said. *You have eyes. You didn't see what was in front of you. You didn't see the Lord, or His mercy, or the poor folks of His church sitting here on the grass. You came to look, and you didn't see. I'm the blind one here, and I tell you there's not more than a handful in this yard with eyes. The ones that know Him have eyes. That's all.*

And then he said it the way he said everything, by heart.

> *He raiseth up the poor out of the dust, and lifteth up the beggar from the dunghill, to set them among princes, and to make them inherit the throne of glory.*
>
> *— 1 Samuel 2:8*

> *The people that walked in darkness have seen a great light: they that dwell in the land of the shadow of death, upon them hath the light shined.*
>
> *— Isaiah 9:2*

Some of the people in that yard said for the rest of their lives that they had seen something that afternoon. They did not mean the lilies. Moses Freeman and Isaac Wicket went down into Mashpee pond together at the end of September and Brother Simon baptized them both, standing waist deep among the pads, with Lemuel holding his elbow. Moses put a new roof on the meeting house that fall, and Isaac paid for the shingles, and between them, over the next ten years, they gave away most of what they had.

VII. The Try-Works

The meeting house steps · evening

THAT EVENING A CROWD OF THEM SAT ON THE MEETING HOUSE steps in the long light, still talking about it. *Did you ever see such a thing. Lilies out of a fire. Did you ever in your life.*

Brother Simon came up the path on Lemuel's arm and asked what they were saying, and they told him.

Well, he said, and sat down on the bottom step. *It's not the first time.*

And because they asked him, he told them.

When he was nineteen he was on a bark out of New Bedford, in the Indian Ocean. There was an old Portuguese cook in the forecastle with the fever who had not eaten in seven days, and the boy had a pannikin of soup for him, carrying it forward. They were trying out a whale that night, boiling down the blubber in the try-pots on deck, with the fire

roaring in the brick try-works under them, and the ship pitched, and one of the pots went over. In a moment the deck between him and the forecastle was a sheet of burning oil, blue and yellow, running in the scuppers.

Every man on deck backed off from it. And Simon Hosea, nineteen years old, looked up, and saw a man standing in the rigging over the fire, laughing. Nobody else saw him. He said the man was well dressed.

I asked him did he light it, said Brother Simon. *He said he did. I asked him why. He said to keep me from bringing the old man his supper, and to let the old man starve. So I told him he could do as he liked, but I was bringing the old man his supper. And I walked out onto it.*

He said something came up under his feet. He did not know what. Something soft and cool, all the way across, and a dust came off it like gold and covered him from his head to his boots, and the man in the rigging was gone, and the old cook ate his soup.

That was the last thing I ever saw, he said. *Gold. My eyes went after that, from the fire, the doctor in Honolulu said. I don't know. I've been looking at it ever since.*

• • •

Moses filled the pit in that fall. The next spring the low place between his house and barn would not dry out, and by June there was standing water in it, a round black pond the size of a room, fed from somewhere underneath, and nobody could ever say from where.

In August there were lilies on it. Every morning that month Moses Freeman picked one with the dew still on it and walked the two miles out the Cotuit road and put it in the old man's hand, and Brother Simon held it up to his face, and breathed it in, and said it was the best one yet.

Background

The verses

> *As on a heap of rubbish cast upon the highway the lily will grow full of sweet perfume and delight, thus the disciple of the truly enlightened Buddha shines forth by his knowledge among those who are like rubbish, among the people that walk in darkness.*
>
> Dhammapada 58–59, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two friends of Sāvatthī are divided by their teachers: Sirigutta follows the Buddha, and Garahadinna follows the Niganṭhas, ascetics who claim to know past, present and future. Tired of being pestered, Sirigutta invites the ascetics to a meal of empty pots and tips them off rigged seats into a ditch of filth, then has them beaten. Garahadinna takes him to the king, who rules against Garahadinna. In revenge, Garahadinna invites the Buddha to a feast over a hidden pit of blazing charcoal and asks him to walk in first, alone. Lotuses as big as wheels rise from the coals, the empty pots fill with exactly what Garahadinna claimed they held, and the Buddha speaks of the lotus that grows from a rubbish heap by the road. Both friends enter the stream. That evening the Buddha tells of a past life in which he walked over a fiery pit made by Māra to feed a holy man, and a lotus rose beneath his feet. Read the full commentary story, or about the lotus.

Mashpee, Massachusetts

Mashpee, 1878

Mashpee on Cape Cod was a Wampanoag community governed for generations as a plantation and district under state control. In 1833 its people, with the Pequot preacher William Apess, staged the Woodland Revolt to win back some self-government. The town's first Baptist congregation was gathered by Blind Joe Amos, a Mashpee preacher born in 1805 and totally blind, who learned the Bible by heart from his mother's reading and was ordained in 1830. After Massachusetts passed its

1869 act making Indians citizens, the state incorporated Mashpee as a town in May 1870, over many residents' objections, which opened its land to sale. Amos had told the legislature's committee, *we are not ready for it now.* Mashpee men went whaling out of New Bedford, cut cordwood and worked the bogs and shellfish beds. The clambake, cooked on red-hot stones under rockweed, is an old Wampanoag way of cooking.

In 1877 Spiritualists held their first camp meeting at Onset Bay in Wareham, which soon became one of the country's leading centers of the movement. Mediums there and elsewhere claimed to carry messages from the dead, and over the 1870s it became common for them to speak through "Indian" spirit controls, invented chiefs and maidens. The Onset camp later declined amid exposures of fraudulent mediums. More on Spiritualism.

After the story of Garahadinna from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 58–59). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 5

The Fool

5.1

Stay Time

> *All motions may be accelerated and retarded, but the True, or equable progress, of Absolute time is liable to no change.*
> *— Isaac Newton, Principia, tr. Andrew Motte (1729)*

The way it was told on the graveyard bus, out of Richland.

I. The White Car

Richland, Washington · August 1955

Nobody in Richland owned his house that year. The government owned the houses and the lawns and the shade trees it had planted on them, and General Electric ran the town for the government the same as it ran the plant. A man's rank on the project settled which letter of house he was let to rent. An operator got half of an A house. A chief supervisor got a D or a G. If a light bulb burned out you filled in a requisition and a man came with a bulb. The house went with the job, and the job went with the clearance, and the people who could take away all three with one telephone call were the managers. That was what it was to be a manager in that town. Russell Sennett was manager of Separations, which meant both of the 200 Areas, East and West, and every tank that was buried in them.

On the Saturday of Atomic Frontier Days the parade came down George Washington Way the way it did every August: the high school band, who were called the Bombers, and the sheriff's posse, and the queen and her court, and floats with *WE'RE HERE TO STAY* lettered down their sides. Behind the General Electric float came a white Buick convertible lent by a dealer in Pasco. Sennett stood up in the back of it in a white hat, and his wife sat by his knees under a white umbrella, because

the sun on that street in August would raise a blister on paint. The Patrol walked the curbs with their arms out to keep the people back. People stood on car hoods and on one another's shoulders to see.

The Desert Inn fronted the street. As the white car came abreast of it, a maid on the upper floor ran up a window to shake out a dust cloth, looked down at the man standing in the car, drew her head in and shut the window. That was all. To Sennett it was as if the moon had come out full and gone straight into a cloud. He turned to keep the window in sight, and the car went on, and his feet went with the car and the rest of him did not. He would have gone over the side if his wife had not put up one hand and taken hold of his belt. People laughed. He laughed too, and waved his hat.

That evening he spoke to Hal Brisco, who was his assistant and went where he was sent.

The hotel. Upstairs, the end window on the street side. Did you see it?

I saw it.

Did you see a woman?

I saw her.

Find out if she's married.

Brisco found out before the fireworks. *Married. The name is Minton. The husband is a pipefitter on construction, and they live in the trailer camp at North Richland.*

Have him in my office Monday morning.

Arlo Minton was from Yell County, Arkansas, and had followed construction to the project in 1948 with a wife and a house trailer. When word came that the manager of Separations wanted him by name, he thought: this is about Neva, and I am in trouble on account of her. He had seen men look at her before. But you did not stay home when a manager sent for you. He washed and went.

From this morning you work for me, Sennett said. *Driver.*

Mr. Sennett, I'm a fitter. I'd as soon stay with my tools and pay my own way.

I don't want your way paid. You're on my staff as of now.

The men who drove for managers were carried on the books of the Patrol, so they gave Arlo Minton a badge and a .38 revolver and took his

name off the union's rolls. A fitter with a wrenched back could lay off a shift, and the steward would speak for him. A manager's driver could not have a back. He went where he was told, when he was told, and there was nobody to speak for him at all.

What Sennett had in mind, they said afterward, was simple. Find the man at fault in something, break him for it, and then see about the wife. Arlo knew it as well as if it had been read out to him. For three weeks he drove the manager's car like a man carrying a full cup. He was early. The car shone. He spoke when he was spoken to and kept his eyes off the mirror. Sennett watched him three weeks for a fault and found none, and the wanting got no smaller for the wait. So he made up his mind to supply one.

II. Six White, Six Blue

The river above town · the last Saturday in August

He called Arlo to the back step a little before three, in the worst of a day that went to a hundred and two.

Go up the river to the old pump house. It's a good three miles. There's a bank of red clay there and a backwater with water lilies in it. I want a pail of the clay and a dozen lilies, six white and six blue, on this step at six o'clock when I come up from my swim. Leave the car. I may want it. If you are not here at six you can turn in your badge.

Arlo stood there. There was no red clay on that river. He had driven the length of the project, and the ground in that country was gray sand and gray cobble and sagebrush, and upriver the bluffs stood as white as flour. The Columbia came down past Richland cold and fast over stones, and nothing rooted in it. He had seen white lilies on the oxbow lakes at home. A blue one he had never seen anywhere.

But the order was given, and a man on staff went. He went by the trailer first, close to running.

Neva, is dinner cooked?

It's on. The beans want another hour.

I haven't got an hour.

He had her ladle them out of the pot into a lard pail, wet as they were, with the salt pork on top and a pone of cornbread on top of that. He pushed the lid down and took a jar of water and went up the river road half running, the pail knocking against his leg. By the time he reached the pump house the beans were done. The pail and the sun had finished them between them.

He sat down under the willows, because a man who is going to be ruined at six may as well eat at four. He set the best of it to one side first, on the lid: the piece of pork and the brown top of the cornbread. He had not taken three bites of the rest when a man came along the bank with a bedroll on his shoulder, a Black man of fifty or so, gray with dust to the knees. He had been walking since daylight and meant to be through Kennewick and over the bridge into East Pasco before dark, because a man of his color did not let the sun go down on him in Kennewick. From Pasco he was going to ride a freight to the hop harvest up the Yakima.

Mister, Arlo said, *I set the best of this to one side before I started. Sit down and eat it.*

The man sat down and ate it, and thanked him, and went on down the bank.

When Arlo had finished he shook the last handful of beans out of the pail into the river, where the suckers came up and took them. He rinsed his mouth. Then he stood up on the bank and said it out loud, having nobody else to say it to.

Whoever lives in this river, hear me. Mr. Sennett is looking for cause to finish me, and he has sent me for red clay and water lilies, white ones and blue ones. I fed a traveling man the best I had. That ought to count for something. I fed your fish. That ought to count a little. Whatever the two of them are worth, I sign it over to you. Bring me red clay and water lilies, white and blue.

He said it three times, loud, and felt like a fool each time.

An old man came up out of the willows below him. He wore a canvas coat buttoned to the neck in that heat, and he was wet to the hips, though there had been no splash. His eyes were small and set far apart, and they looked as if they had been open a long time.

What's that you're saying?

Arlo said it again.

Sign it over to me, the old man said.

It's yours.

Sign it over to me.

I do. It's yours.

Sign it over.

It's yours, mister. All of it.

The old man picked up the empty lard pail and went down through the willows. He was gone about as long as it takes to roll a cigarette. He came back with the pail full to the bail of clay as red as a new brick, and cold, and over his arm twelve water lilies, six white and six blue, each with a yard of stem and the river still running out of it. He put them into Arlo's hands and went back the way he had come. Arlo did not hear him go into the water that time either.

Then there were the three miles back. It was past five. The pail weighed better than fifteen pounds and the wire bail cut into his fingers, one hand and then the other, and he had the lilies rolled in his wet shirt against the sun. He had walked three miles more times than he could count and had never known there was so much in them. Every hundred yards he looked for the first roofs of town, and they were where they had been. He did not stop, because he did not think he would start again.

III. The Gate

The river houses · ten minutes to six

Sennett had been thinking too. A man in a corner will turn up anything, he thought. If he comes back with it, I am no further on than I was. So at five he had the yardman chain the gate. The Sennetts' was the one house on that street with a fence; the government had put it up for some manager before him. He took the key off the yardman's ring himself and carried it upstairs and laid it on his dresser.

Arlo came down the street at ten minutes to six by the watch on his wrist, and the gate was chained.

Open it, Orrin.

I can't. He had me lock up at five, and he's got the key upstairs.

I'm his driver. He sent me. Open the gate.

I know who you are, Arlo. I can't.

Arlo stood a minute with the pail in his hand. Then he tipped the red clay out on the walk in front of the gate, all of it in one heap, and hung the lilies on the pickets, six white and six blue. It was the hour when Richland watered. Up and down the street people were out on the government grass moving their sprinklers. He turned around to them and called out, and his voice carried.

All you people on this street, I want you for witnesses. It is not six o'clock. I have done what Mr. Sennett sent me to do. There is his clay and there are his lilies. He is looking for cause to finish me, and I have not given him any.

Three times he called it. People stood holding their hoses. Nobody answered him, but they had heard.

Then he thought: where do I go? The trailer was the first place they would come. And he thought of Miss Whitlow.

In good times there were people in the trailer camp who did not think of Lenora Whitlow from one month to the next. She was a woman past fifty who lived by herself at the end of a row, in a trailer with a canvas awning and a cot under the awning, and what was known about her was that she had never turned anybody off her step. People remembered where she lived when they were in trouble.

She was a radiation monitor on the tank farms in 200 West. She had taught physics in the high school at Walla Walla and hired on in forty-four, when the project paid three times what a school board did, and she had stayed. Her work was to go down onto a job ahead of the crew with the meter the men called a cutie pie, and read it, and come back and tell each man how long he had. Four minutes. Ninety seconds. Eleven minutes, and not twelve. She held the watch, and when she said out, they came out, fitters and millwrights and foremen alike. They called it a man's stay time, or just his time. Operators who would not take an engineer's word took hers.

She looked at Arlo Minton standing in her gravel with his shirt in his hand and the marks of the bail across his fingers, and she did not ask him anything.

There's the cot, she said. *There's water in the jug.*

She sent a child down the rows to tell Neva where he was. He lay down, and he was asleep before the light went.

IV. Four Sounds

That night, and Sunday

SENNETT ATE A STEAK THAT NIGHT AND COULD NOT HAVE SAID afterward what it was. He went to bed and did not sleep. He lay with the fan going and looked at the ceiling and thought about a window in the Desert Inn. In the morning, he thought, I will have his badge for leaving his post, and Decker can find the rest. A man from Arkansas has a cousin somewhere who signed something once. He will be off the project by Wednesday and out of the camp by Friday, and she will be in that trailer by herself with the lot rent due. Under that he thought about how wide the reservation was at night and how few roads crossed it, and he did not let himself finish the thought.

He heard the clock downstairs strike twelve, and then one. A little after one he heard something else.

It came from the north, from the direction of the areas, across thirty miles of sagebrush, and it came in at his window as plain as the clock. Four sounds, one after another, low. *Duh. Suh. Nuh. So.* Each one was a man's voice starting to say something, and each was cut off before the second word, as if the man had been pulled under.

Sennett sat up with the sweat gone cold on him. Is it me? he thought. Is it Jess? Is it the plant? He did not lie down again. He sat on the edge of the bed until the window went gray, and nobody had ever told him a night could have that much in it.

On Sunday morning he sent for Decker. Decker was head of Security for Separations. He had been eleven years with the Bureau before he

came to the project, and it was understood that he knew how things were read in Washington.

I heard something last night, Sennett said. *After one o'clock. From out toward the areas.*

What did you hear?

Duh. Suh. Nuh. So. Like that. Four of them.

Decker had no more idea what it meant than the chair he sat in. But a security man who says he does not know is a security man the project can do without, and he knew that much.

That's serious, he said.

How serious?

It means you're through. Somebody is signaling somebody, on your ground, on your watch. When that gets back East they will want a name, and the name on Separations is yours.

Sennett's fear doubled. *Is there any way around it?*

There is. Don't worry. I know how they read these things. You get out ahead of it. You give them a housecleaning before they ask for one.

What do you need?

Names. Ten from every shop. Ten operators, ten fitters, ten electricians, ten millwrights, ten riggers, ten truck drivers, ten bus drivers, ten patrolmen, ten out of the laundry, ten girls from the counting rooms, ten out of the dormitories. Clearances pulled, pending review.

He was thinking as he said it: if I hand him nothing but craft, they will say Security is going after the unions. So he added, *And ten engineers. And a chemist or two.*

Do it, Sennett said. He was thinking: I will keep what I have, whatever it costs.

Decker's men worked through Sunday in the files and came in with more names than they had been asked for. On Monday morning a hundred and forty people were put off the buses at the barricades and their badges taken. By Monday noon a man from Housing was walking the streets of Richland with a pad of notices, because the house went with the job. He tacked them to the doors. Women stood on the porches of A houses and B houses and prefabs with the paper in their hands. Children

were called in from the yards. By the middle of the afternoon the sound in that town was like the sound of ground giving way.

V. Both Areas

The river houses · Monday

Jessamine Sennett had found the lilies on Saturday evening, hung on her own gate, six white and six blue, and the red clay heaped on the walk. She asked the yardman, and the yardman, who was more afraid of her than of her husband, told her. She said nothing about it then. She carried the lilies in and floated them in the big glass bowl on the dining table, and she left the clay where it lay.

On Monday the wives came to her back door, two and three at a time, with the notices. She heard them out. Then she went upstairs, where her husband sat on the side of the bed in his undershirt with the blinds down.

Russell, what ails you? You look like something that's been dug up.

Don't you know, Jess? A snake has got in at my ear. He told her about the four sounds, and Decker, and the lists. *Decker says I'm through unless I clean house. I mean to keep what I've got.*

You are a fool, she said. *You eat a steak and three eggs every morning of your life, and you have both the areas under you, East and West, and you have not got the sense God gave a goose. Where did you ever hear of one man saving himself by finishing another? And a hundred and forty of them? Because a man who had no idea what you heard was afraid to say so? There is a woman on your own tank farms who knows every sound that ground makes. Your operators won't go down on a tank till she has told them how long. Go and ask her what you heard, and then do what she tells you.*

VI. The Watch

The trailer camp, North Richland · Monday evening

They went in her car, the little Nash, and she drove. The trailer camp had been laid out for better than two thousand trailers

AND WAS MORE THAN HALF EMPTY BY THEN, LOT AFTER LOT OF bare gravel, each with its board sunshade standing over nothing. Miss Whitlow's was the last lot of the last row. She was sitting on her step in what was left of the light. Under the awning, on the cot, sat Arlo Minton, who had been there since Saturday night.

Sennett got out of the car and stood in the gravel. He had not slept in two nights, and he was so afraid of what he was going to be told that he could not get a word out. He took off his hat and stood to one side, holding it.

It was Miss Whitlow who spoke. *You've come late in the day, Mr. Sennett.*

He said nothing. Jessamine told it for him: the sounds after one o'clock on Saturday night, and what Decker had made of them, and the lists, and the paper on the doors. *That is why I've brought him to you,* she said.

Is that so, Mr. Sennett?

Yes, ma'am.

What did you hear?

He told her, as near as he could make the sounds. *Duh. Suh. Nuh. So.*

Miss Whitlow sat a moment without saying anything. Then she said, *You needn't be afraid. It doesn't mean you're through. Those are men in a bad place, saying how it is with them.*

What did they do? Sennett said.

That was before your time on the project, she said. *In forty-four there were better than forty thousand people on construction, living in the camp at Hanford, and among them were four pipefitters from four different states who were as thick as thieves. They were drawing more money in a week than their fathers saw in a season, and there was nothing out there to spend it on. That July the whole camp gave a day's pay, every man and woman in it, and bought the Army a bomber, and they named the airplane Day's Pay. Those four talked it over in the beer hall, whether to put in. They talked over whether to send any home. Not one of them was for it. One said, let's eat steak and drink whiskey as long as it lasts. One said cards. One said there were houses in Pasco. And the fourth one said, boys, there is not a woman in the trailer camp who won't listen to a man with money in his hand. Let's spend it on other men's wives. That suited all four.*

It is what they did, to the end of the job and a good while after, as long as the money held.

They are dead now, all four. I could tell you how, and it would not signify. The operators say they are out in the farms. I can't tell you where men go, Mr. Sennett. I can tell you what I have read off a meter. The new tanks are self-boiling. What is in them makes its own heat. Nobody lit a fire under them and nobody can put one out. The liquor turns over like beans in a pot: down the wall, along the bottom, up the middle. And there are four tanks, S-101, S-104, SX-101 and SX-104, those four and no others, where every so often the bottom gets ahead of the top and the whole tank heaves. We call it a bump. Engineering cannot tell me why those four. The operators say it is a man who has been all the way down and all the way back up, and has his head out for one breath, and has something he wants to say, and gets one sound of it out before the tank rolls him under.

What was the first one you heard?

Duh, said Sennett.

I have stood over those tanks eleven years with a watch, she said. *I know how they go on.* And she finished it for the man who could not.

Done wrong, the whole of it, the way we lived. We had it in both hands and gave none. Out of all that money we never made ourselves one island to stand on.

And the next?

Suh.

Sunk sixty thousand years, all told, down and back. When does it end?

Nuh.

None. No end. Where would an end come from? Nobody can see one. We cooked this ourselves, friend, you and I.

So.

So when I get out of here, and get a man's life again, I will give with both hands, and keep straight, and do a world of good.

That is what you heard, she said. *Four men, one word apiece. And they are in there yet.*

Sixty thousand years, Sennett said.

I don't know how the operators came by the figure. I know how I would. The heat in those tanks is short-lived. Three hundred years will see to most of it. But there is plutonium in the sludge that the plant did not get, and half of it will still be there in twenty-four thousand years. In sixty thousand there will be better than a sixth of it yet.

Sennett stood in the gravel with his hat in his hands. He was thinking: those four went after other men's wives, and that is where it has put them, and it is not over. I set my heart on one man's wife and got one night out of it, awake. I am done with that. He said the only part of it he could say.

Miss Whitlow, I found out Saturday how long a night is.

Arlo Minton spoke from the cot. Nobody had asked him. *Mr. Sennett found out Saturday night how long a night is. Saturday afternoon I found out how long three miles is.*

Miss Whitlow got up and went into the trailer and came out with a book, an old tall one in a calf binding that had been her father's. She held it to the light from the door and read to them.

> *Absolute, True, and Mathematical Time, of it self, and from its own nature, flows equably without relation to anything external, and by another name is called Duration: Relative, Apparent, and Common Time, is some sensible and external (whether accurate or unequable) measure of Duration by the means of motion, which is commonly used instead of True time; such as an Hour, a Day, a Month, a Year.*
>
> *All motions may be accelerated and retarded, but the True, or equable progress, of Absolute time is liable to no change. The duration or perseverance of the existence of things remains the same, whether the motions are swift or slow, or none at all.*
>
> *— Isaac Newton, Principia, Scholium to the Definitions, tr. Andrew Motte (1729)*

Common time, she said. *The hour, the day. A mile is the same kind of thing. Saturday night was the same eight hours on that cot as it was in your bed, Mr. Sennett. He slept through his. The road to the pump house is three miles for*

anybody. I have seen him drive it in five minutes. None of that stretches. On the farms I tell a man he has four minutes, and for one man it is nothing, and the next will swear it was the longest four minutes he ever spent on the end of a wrench. It is the same four minutes. I am the one holding the watch.

What was long was you. She moved her head toward the north. *And what is long out there is long for people who make a thing and never learn the law it goes by. It will take its own time. It will not hurry for a manager.*

What do I do? Sennett said.

Go and let those people go.

• • •

He drove to the 700 Area himself that night and had Decker out of bed, and the lists were torn up in front of him. On Tuesday morning the badges were waiting at the barricades with the names called off, and the man from Housing went back down the same streets and took his notices off the doors. The women washed their hair and went back into their houses. At the clotheslines that week, and on the buses for years, the name that was said was Jessamine Sennett's.

Arlo Minton asked for his tools back and got them. They said afterward that something had settled in him on that cot. He was a man who could not be frightened after that by Sennett or by anyone, and it lasted him the rest of his life. Neva went on making beds at the Desert Inn and shook her dust cloths out of the back windows. Sennett did not look up at the front ones again.

On the buses they said it was not Mrs. Sennett's first time. At Old Hickory in 1918, when she was nineteen and three weeks married to the youngest foreman on the powder line, a new superintendent had sworn that the day he got the plant he would discharge every foreman who had stood in his way. He got the plant. He had ninety-nine letters signed and sent for the hundredth man, and she came in her husband's place and stood in front of the desk laughing and crying at once. He asked her if she had lost her mind. She said that the month before, when company came and the store had no meat, she had cut the throat of a ewe that was lying behind the house. One ewe. She had dreamed every night since that

the throat was her own, and she expected to go on dreaming it a night for every hair that ewe had on her. *That is what I'm crying about,* she said. *I'm laughing because I only did the one, and here you sit about to do a hundred.* He burned the letters in his wastebasket. Some of the people who told it had it from people who were in the building.

• • •

The blue lilies stood in the glass bowl on the Sennetts' table into October, long after the white ones had gone brown. Nobody in that country had seen one before, and nobody has seen one since. The government sold Richland to the people who lived in it a few years later. The clay is still on the walk in front of that gate. The people who bought the house have scrubbed at it and painted over it, and in a wet spring it comes up through the paint, a red place the size of a washtub.

The tanks are still in the ground too. In the fall of 2025 the plant they built on the plateau poured its first glass. It has been seventy-one years since the night Sennett sat up in his bed, and by the operators' count the four of them have all but sixty thousand still to go. Nobody has yet heard one of them get to the end of his sentence.

Background

The verse

> *Long is the night to him who is awake; long is a mile to him who is tired; long is life to the foolish who do not know the true law.*
>
> Dhammapada 60, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi of Kosala, riding his white elephant around the city on a festival day, sees a poor man's wife at an upper window and wants her. He makes the husband his servant, finds no fault in him, and sends him a league to fetch red earth and white and blue water lilies that grow only in the country of the nāgas. The man shares his half-cooked rice with a traveler and the fish, makes over the merit to whoever lives in the pool, and a nāga king in the form of an old man brings him what he needs. The king has shut the gate early; the man hangs the flowers on it, calls the city to witness and goes to sleep at the monastery. That night the sleep-

less king hears four syllables, *du, sa, na, so*, cried by four adulterers in the Iron Caldron hell, each of whom rises to the rim once in sixty thousand years and can get out only the first sound of a verse. His chaplain reads them as an omen of the king's death and prescribes a great sacrifice of living creatures; Queen Mallikā calls him a fool and takes him to the Buddha, who finishes the four verses. The king says he has learned how long a night is, the servant how long a league is, and the Buddha joins their words. The sacrifice is called off. A story of the past tells how Mallikā, as Queen Dinnā, once saved a hundred kings by weeping and laughing over a ewe she had killed. Read the full commentary story, or about Pasenadi.

Richland, Washington

Richland and the Hanford tank farms, 1955

Richland was rebuilt by the Army in 1943 as the operators' town for the Hanford plutonium works. Until the houses began to be sold to their tenants in 1957, all of it was government property managed by the contractor, which after 1946 was General Electric. Rank decided which of the lettered “alphabet houses” a family could rent, and a burned-out bulb was replaced on requisition. Construction workers lived apart, first in the wartime camp at Hanford, whose people gave a day's wages in 1944 to buy the B-17 *Day's Pay*, and later in the trailer camp at North Richland. Atomic Frontier Days, with its parade and floats reading “We're Here to Stay,” ran from 1948. Black workers recruited for the wartime construction were kept out of Richland and out of Kennewick, a sundown town, and lived in East Pasco. Sennett, his household, Decker's purge and Miss Whitlow are invented; no such mass suspension took place.

The chemical plants in the 200 Areas dissolved irradiated fuel and sent the leftover liquor to underground steel-lined tanks. Waste from the REDOX plant, which started in 1952, was hot enough to boil on its own decay heat, and the S and SX tank farms in 200 West were built to take it. Engineers called the sudden steam surges in these tanks “bumping.” A later engineering review records that before May 1955 it had been seen only in tanks S-101, S-104 and SX-101, and afterward in SX-104: four tanks. Radiation monitors with hand-held ion chambers nicknamed “cutie pies” set

the time a worker could spend on a job. Plutonium-239 has a half-life of about 24,100 years, so roughly eighteen percent of any quantity remains after sixty thousand. Hanford still holds about 56 million gallons of waste in 177 tanks; the first of it was turned to glass in October 2025. Newton's distinction between absolute and common time is in the Scholium that follows the Definitions of the *Principia*, here in Andrew Motte's English of 1729.

After the story of a certain man from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 60). The original. The passage on time is from Isaac Newton's *Principia* in the translation of Andrew Motte (1729). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

5.2

Swallow Mud

Better a house, though a hut it be,
A man is master at home;
A pair of goats and a patched-up roof
Are better far than begging.
— Hávamál 36

The way I had it told, on the Shin Pond road.

I. The Water

Shin Pond road, above Patten · October 2016

Wendell Kasper had piped steam in the Millinocket mill for thirty-one years, and when the mill shut he drove north past Patten and up a logging spur off the Shin Pond road and built a cabin at the end of it, and he had lived there alone since. He was seventy-one. He ate once a day, at noon. He slept on a bed of spruce poles under two wool blankets. He hauled his water from the brook in two pails because the brook was there, and he had patched his roof so many times, with tarpaper and cedar bark and the flattened lids of coffee cans, that the kindred said it was the swallows holding it up. Every May the barn swallows came back and plastered their mud cups under the eave over his door, and nobody was allowed to knock them down.

Behind the cabin, in a ring of white birches, stood the hof: a lean-to of rough hemlock boards, a flat stone in front of it, a plank table. On the old feast days eight or nine people drove in from Patten and Sherman and Island Falls, and now and then somebody from Bangor, to make blót there. They poured mead into a maple bowl and lifted it to the gods and shook it with a sprig of fir over the stone and over one another. Then they sat at

the plank table and passed the horn. Kasper was their gothi because he had been reading the old poems longer than any of them. He had found the Eddas in the Millinocket library in 1986 and read them on his breaks in the boiler house, and he still had the library's copy, which he said he had paid for twice over in fines. He did not preach. When the young ones asked him what the gods wanted, he said they wanted the wood split.

That fall two young men were living with him.

Toby Michaud was twenty-four and from East Millinocket, where his father had worked in the mill until it closed in 2014 and then had not worked anywhere until he died. Toby came up the spur in his mother's Buick in June to ask whether the old man needed help, and stayed. He was a big, quiet boy who did a thing and then did the next thing. He was up before Kasper every morning to set out the enamel basin of hot water and the razor on a folded towel. He split wood, carried water, shoveled the ashes out, and banked the stove at night.

Brody Leeman was from Bangor and twenty-seven. He had found Kasper on the internet, in a picture somebody posted from Midsummer of the old man in front of the hof with his beard down his chest and the horn raised, and he wrote to Toby asking if the gothi took students. He came in August with a phone and a pack and a bag of runes he had bought online, and he could talk about the gods for an hour without stopping. He was good company at the table. When there was wood to be split he was usually somewhere else.

He had a way of getting to Kasper first. Toby would set out the basin and go back out to the woodpile, and Brody would come in from the outhouse and say, *Water's on, Wendell. Go ahead and wash.* Toby would carry six pails up from the brook to fill the reservoir on the cookstove, and at noon Brody would say, *Reservoir's full.* At the full-moon sumbel, when the horn went around and each one stood to boast of a thing done, Brody boasted the cord of rock maple stacked against the north wall. Toby, who had stacked it, drank when the horn came to him and said nothing.

Kasper bathed on Saturday nights in a galvanized tub in the back room. It took the canner and both kettles and a five-gallon milk can

heated all afternoon on the cookstove to fill it halfway. On a Saturday in October, Toby had had enough.

He did not say so to anyone. After the noon meal, while Brody slept on the bunk with his phone face down on his chest, Toby heated the water the way he always did. Then he carried the milk can and the canner out to the woodshed and set them by the chopping block under a horse blanket to keep hot, and on the cookstove he left one small saucepan with an inch of water in the bottom, steaming. Then he took the rifle and went up the spur after a deer he had seen.

Brody woke at four and saw the steam. He went to Kasper, who was darning a mitten by the window, and said, *Bath's in, Wendell. Go on and get in while it's hot,* and walked him to the back room himself.

The tub was dry.

Where's the water, son?

Brody went back to the stove and put the dipper in the saucepan and struck bottom. *Will you look at that,* he said. *He set a pot of nothing on the stove and took off. Who knows where. I saw the steam and figured.* He said some other things about Toby. Then he grabbed both pails off their nails and banged out the door and down the path toward the brook, as if it were the old man who had done something to him.

Toby came back at dusk without a deer. He went to the shed and carried in the milk can and the canner and filled the tub, and Kasper sat in it with his knees up and thought for a long time.

When Brody came up the path in the dark with his pails half spilled, the old man was dressed and sitting by the lamp.

Sit down, Kasper said. Brody sat. *One of us doesn't say he's done a thing unless he's done it. You came and told me the water was in. Then when there wasn't any, you went off mad to the brook. That's no way to be.*

That was all. He went back to the mitten.

Brody lay awake on the bunk most of the night. A few gallons of water. He had carried plenty of water. The old man had made him out a liar in front of Toby over a few gallons of water.

In the morning, when Kasper went out to the truck to go down to Patten for his mail and his Sunday rounds, Brody said his back was bad and he would stay. So Kasper took Toby.

II. The Stew

Stacyville · the end of October

Karen Ouellette kept forty Romney ewes on a hill farm in Stacyville and wove. She was not one of the kindred. She went to Mass in Patten when she went. But she had known Kasper since her husband ran the paper machines and Kasper kept their steam up, and since her husband died she had fed the old man his one meal every Sunday at her kitchen table, as other people in those towns did on other days. He went around to them the way the mail went around: Karen on Sundays, the Hersey family in Sherman on Wednesdays, the diner in Patten when somebody there had a birthday.

Two weeks before, at the Winter Nights blót, Karen had come up the spur with a cloak she had woven him on the big loom in her parlor, a heavy grey twill as long as a bedspread, with a fringe. Kasper put it on and thanked her and wore it home. The next morning he folded it over the back of Toby's chair. *I've got a coat,* he said. Toby gathered butternut hulls along Fish Stream and boiled the cloak in the canner until it came out the brown of strong tea, and cut it with Kasper's tin snips, which was the only shears on the place, into a long coat and a short cape. Brody had watched him do it.

That Sunday, while Kasper and Toby were at the Herseys' helping put in a stovepipe, Brody drove his Subaru down to Stacyville. Karen came out wiping her hands.

Where's Wendell?

He's poorly, Brody said. *Took a chill. He's staying in bed.*

Well, for heaven's sake. What does he want?

Brody said Wendell had said that if she was making anything, a chicken stew would go down good, and maybe some of her biscuits, and maybe if there was any of that apple pie. He said it as if he were reading it off a

list the old man had written. Karen went in and made the stew from scratch with one of her own hens and put it in a quart jar wrapped in a dish towel, and a dozen biscuits in a bread bag, and half a pie on a paper plate, and sent her love.

Brody ate it at the turnout by the Fish Stream bridge with the engine running for the heat. He ate the biscuits and the stew and the pie with his fingers, and threw the jar in the brush.

The next Sunday Kasper came into Karen's kitchen and stamped the snow off and sat down.

Look at you, she said. *Your boy said you were flat on your back. I sent up stew. I guess it did you good.*

Kasper said nothing. He ate what she put in front of him and thanked her for it and drove home.

That evening he said to Brody, *I hear you went to Karen's last Sunday and told her I was sick.* He waited, and Brody did not answer. *That's not a thing we do. You don't eat food you got by letting on it was for somebody else.*

Brody went out to the outhouse and sat in it in the cold for an hour.

A few gallons of water. A jar of stew. He went over it and over it. Called a liar over the water, and now a thief over a jar of stew, a fistful of food the woman would have given him anyway if he had asked her. And the cloak. A cloak she wove for the gothi, and the old man handed it to Toby like it was a dish towel, and Toby had gone and made himself a coat of it, and walked around in it now. It was plain how things stood. He said it to himself in the dark until he believed it. The old man had treated him like dirt from the start. Well, he knew what to do about that.

III. The Maul

The first snow · November

On the Saturday after the first snow, Kasper drove down to Patten for his mail and the kerosene, and Toby went with him, and Brody stayed.

He started with the horns. There were two drinking horns on pegs by the door. Kasper had made the long one himself in 1991 from a steer horn

he got off a farm in Littleton, boiled and scraped and polished with ashes until you could see a candle through it, and every blót the kindred had made in twenty-five years had been drunk out of it. Brody took them down and broke them across the edge of the cookstove. He took the maple bowl from the hof, and when it would not break he split it with the axe. He swept the shelves with the axe handle, and down came the jars, sixty or seventy quarts of beans and venison and fiddleheads and blueberries, which was the old man's winter, and the lamp chimneys and the enamel basin and the mugs. Then he poured the kerosene from the lamp can over the bunk and the books and the tarpaper and lit it, and went out back and lit the hof.

When he had watched it for a while he went and got the eight-pound maul from the chopping block. Whatever would not burn he went after. He beat in the side of the galvanized tub. He swung at the cookstove until a leg went and the firebox cracked across. He broke the flat stone in front of the hof into three pieces. Last of all he reached up and knocked the swallows' nests off the eave with the maul handle, though they had been empty since August, and the dry mud came down in the snow in little grey cups and broke.

Then he got in the Subaru and drove away down the Shin Pond road.

Kasper and Toby saw the smoke from the bridge. By the time they came up the spur there was nothing to do. The cabin was a black square in the snow with the stovepipe standing up out of it, and the hof was a few charred posts in the ring of birches. Toby ran about with a pail. Kasper stood in the dooryard in his old coat and looked at it.

Then he went and knelt in the wet ash by the door and picked up a curved piece of the long horn about the size of his hand. He turned it over and put it in his coat pocket, and got up, and told Toby to stop.

Karen took them in. Kasper slept that winter in her back bedroom off the kitchen, under a quilt, and said it was too soft, and Toby slept on the parlor couch beside the loom.

• • •

The towns talked about it all winter. At the Patten diner and the post office and the transfer station they said a fella from Bangor had burned out old Kasper up the Shin Pond road over a couple of words, if you could believe that. Burned the house, burned that Viking shed of his, broke the stove with a maul. Over being told something. People who had never had any use for the kindred said it, and people who thought the old man was a crank said it, and they shook their heads.

In January Brody Leeman drove a borrowed pickup out onto Pushaw Lake at two in the morning, where people had been fishing through the ice all week, and found the place where it was thin. The warden service brought the truck up with a winch in the spring. In Patten the kindred heard about it a week after. Dale Hersey, who drove a log truck and did not say much, was in Karen's kitchen when the call came, and he said the lines from the old seeress's poem about the shore of the dead:

> *I saw there wading through rivers wild*
> *Treacherous men and murderers too,*
> *And workers of ill with the wives of men;*
> *There Nithhogg sucked the blood of the slain,*
> *And the wolf tore men; would you know yet more?*
>
> *— Völuspá 39*

Kasper was at the table with his coffee. He did not say anything. He took the piece of horn out of his pocket and set it on the oilcloth and looked at it.

IV. The High Seat

A Grange hall in Dover-Foxcroft · February 2017

In February the kindreds from around the state met for two days in a rented Grange hall in Dover-Foxcroft, and on the Saturday night Ronda Theriault sat the high seat.

She was forty-six and a hospice aide for the county. Most weeks of the year she drove a Honda with a hundred and ninety thousand miles on it

from one farmhouse to another, turning people in their beds and washing them and sitting with them, and twice a year she did this. They had built her a platform at the end of the hall out of folding tables with a kitchen chair on top, and hung blankets around it, and she sat up there in a dark blue cloak with a veil of black net over her face and a staff across her knees. Down on the floor eighty people sat in the dark on metal chairs. A man with a frame drum walked them, in their minds, down the trunk of the great tree, down through the roots and the cold and the mist to the gate of the hall of the dead, and four women sang the old calling song, and when they stopped singing the seeress was somewhere else, and anybody who had a question could come up the aisle and ask it.

Dale Hersey had not meant to ask anything. He had driven down Route 11 in the dark because his wife wanted to come. But the line kept moving, and he found he was in it.

Ronda had known Wendell Kasper since she was fifteen and shelving books on Saturdays at the Millinocket library, when a pipefitter with a beard came in and asked if they had anything on the old Norse gods. She had brought him the Eddas from the back. He had kept them, and twenty years later he had taught her to read the runes at his plank table. That was the only reason Dale could think of afterward for what she said. He came up to the edge of the platform in the dark, and before he could open his mouth the voice came out from under the black net. It was lower and older than Ronda's.

How is it with my son Wendell?

Dale stood there a minute. *He's all right,* he said. *He's at Karen Ouellette's. He's fine. Only one of the boys he took in, the Bangor one, burned him out in November over being spoken to. Burned the house and the hof both. Then he went through the ice on Pushaw in January.*

Nobody in the hall made a sound. The drummer had laid his hand flat on the drum.

That isn't the first time, the voice said. *That one never could stand a word said to him. It isn't the first house he pulled down, either.*

Dale said he did not understand.

I see a barn, said the seeress. *I see a swallow building under the eave of it. I see rain.*

She told it slowly, as if it were going by her a little at a time and she was telling what she saw. A swallow had built her house under the eave of a barn, a cup of mud carried up a mouthful at a time from the edge of the stream and lined with feathers. In a cold rain a raccoon came along the beam, wet to the skin and shivering. The swallow looked out of her house at him.

Raccoon, she said, *you have a face like a man's, and hands like a man's. Why don't you have a house?*

I have the hands, the raccoon said. *I haven't got the sense. The best thing a man has, I haven't got.*

And because the raccoon had stolen eggs from that barn, and lied to the dog about it, and let the cat take the blame, the swallow said to him the thing that was true. *Then it's no wonder. You're light-minded and you're false to your friends, and nothing you promise holds. A house wouldn't do you any good. If you want to be out of the wind, go make one with all your strength, and change your ways.*

The raccoon thought, *She calls me light-minded. She calls me false. I'll show her a thing or two about houses.* He reached up with his clever hands and tore the mud cup off the beam and threw the pieces down in the rain. The swallow was out of it before it fell. She flew off over the field.

The veil turned toward Dale.

That raccoon was the Bangor boy, said the voice. *The swallow was the one we're speaking of. Would you know yet more?*

Dale said no.

He would be better off alone, said the seeress, *than with one like that. If he can't find a better man than himself to walk with, or one as good, let him walk by himself and be glad of it.* And then she said the old lines that the High One gave to the wandering singer, the way a person says something they have known so long it comes out by itself:

I rede thee, Loddfafnir! and hear thou my rede,—
Profit thou hast if thou hearest,
Great thy gain if thou learnest:
A good man find to hold in friendship,
And give heed to his healing charms.

I rede thee, Loddfafnir! and hear thou my rede,—
Profit thou hast if thou hearest,
Great thy gain if thou learnest:
Exchange of words with a witless ape
Thou must not ever make.

— Hávamál 120, 122

Then the singers began again, and Dale went back down the aisle and sat in his metal chair beside his wife, and somebody else went up.

• • •

They drove home on Route 11 a little after midnight. North of Sherman the sky cleared, and at the long rise where you can see the mountain, Dale pulled the truck onto the shoulder and shut the engine off.

Katahdin was white under the moon. His wife asked if he was all right. He said he was. He was fifty-eight years old and had carried a grudge against his own brother since their father's funeral, eleven years, over a remark at the graveside about a chainsaw, and he had been feeding it every day the way you feed a stove. Sitting there he could not find it. He looked for it the way you pat your pockets for your keys. It was not anywhere. There was the mountain and the cold ticking of the engine and his wife's breath on the window, and in his chest, where the thing had been, a feeling like a room after a stove has been taken out of it, a lot of space and a little cold.

He never told anyone about it but her. In March he drove to Medway and knocked on his brother's door.

V. Mud

Shin Pond road · May 2017

The kindred came up the spur on three Saturdays in April when the frost went out and helped raise a new cabin on the old sills. It was smaller than the first one, twelve by sixteen, of spruce logs Toby had cut and peeled over the winter at a woodlot in Stacyville, with a shed roof of second-hand steel that a man in Island Falls took off his barn. Karen gave him a cookstove from her cellar. Somebody from Bangor sent a box of quart jars in the mail with no note.

The flat stone in front of the hof was in three pieces, and Kasper set them back in the ground as close together as they would go and left the cracks between them. He did not rebuild the hof that year. He said the birches would do.

Toby stayed. He wore the butternut coat every day until it was too warm, and then he hung it on a nail by the door. Kasper did not take anyone else in. A young couple from Portland wrote that spring asking whether the gothi took students, and he had Toby write back that he was too old and they should go see Ronda Theriault in Dover-Foxcroft.

On the second Sunday in May, after the noon meal, the old man was sitting on the chopping block in the sun with the piece of horn in his hand when the swallows came back. There were four of them, and they went around and around the cabin in the wind, low, over the place where the old eave had been, and then over the new one. Toby came out of the woods with a pail in each hand and stopped beside him to watch.

The new eave was a raw spruce board, still white, still bleeding a little pitch. One swallow went down to the edge of the brook and came back, and hung there against the board with her wings going, and pressed a pellet of wet mud onto it, and went for another.

Background

The verse

> *If a traveller does not meet with one who is his better, or his equal, let him firmly keep to his solitary journey; there is no companionship with a fool.*
>
> Dhammapada 61, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Mahā Kassapa, the Buddha's great ascetic disciple, lives at the Pipphali Cave near Rājagaha with two young attendants. One does the work; the other takes the credit, telling the elder his bath is ready when the faithful pupil has left only a little water steaming in a pot. Rebuked, the false pupil goes to the elder's lay supporter, says the elder is sick, and eats the food he is given. Rebuked again, and jealous of the fine robes the elder has passed on to the other pupil, he smashes the monastery's vessels, burns the elder's leaf hut, beats what will not burn with a hammer, and runs. He dies and goes to hell. When a monk from Rājagaha brings the news to the Buddha, the Buddha tells the birth story of a monkey who, scolded by a hornbill for having hands like a man and no house, tore the bird's nest to pieces, and speaks the verse. The visiting monk enters the stream. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa.

Shin Pond road near Patten, Maine

The North Woods, 2016

The paper mills built the towns below Katahdin. Great Northern Paper's mills at Millinocket and East Millinocket went through bankruptcy and changes of ownership after 2003; the Millinocket mill shut in 2008 and the last mill in the region, at East Millinocket, closed in 2014, ending several hundred jobs. Millinocket has lost nearly half its 1970 population. On August 24, 2016, President Obama proclaimed the Katahdin Woods and Waters National Monument on 87,563 acres east of Baxter State Park, donated by the family foundation of a Burt's Bees co-founder. Many local

people and the governor bitterly opposed it, and others hoped it would bring visitors back. Its north entrance lies up Route 159, the Shin Pond road, out of Patten.

Heathenry, the modern revival of pre-Christian Germanic and Norse religion, has been practiced in the United States since the 1960s, mostly in small local groups called kindreds. Its central rites are the blót, an offering of mead to the gods sprinkled over the people, and the sumbel, rounds of toasts and boasts over the drinking horn, where words spoken are held to be binding. Its scriptures are the poems of the Poetic Edda, above all the Hávamál, the the "Sayings of the High One,"ldquo;Words of the High One,the "Sayings of the High One,"rdquo; Odin's counsel on hospitality, friendship and good sense. Some groups have also revived oracular seiðr, drawn from the seeress in the Saga of Erik the Red: the seer sits on a high seat while songs and drumming carry the gathering in trance down the world tree toward Hel, and then answers the questions people bring.

After the story of Mahā Kassapa's pupil from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 61). The original. Scripture from the Poetic Edda, translated by Henry Adams Bellows (1923). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5·3

Five Places

> *That even of which a man thinks 'this is mine' is left behind by death.*
> *— Sutta Nipāta 806, tr. V. Fausbøll*

Evaṃ me sutaṃ, in the Lower Highlands.

I. The Chain

Lowell, Massachusetts · 1994

Kong Sarin sold gold on Middlesex Street, in a narrow shop between a video store and a place that wired money to Battambang, and he was the richest Cambodian in the Lower Highlands. Everybody said so, and he never once denied it, because denying it would have meant saying a number.

The gold in his cases was the old kind, the soft deep yellow that bends in the hand. Chains, mostly, and bracelets, and the thick rope necklaces that a family put on a bride and took back off her to pay for a funeral. He weighed everything on a little brass scale and priced it by the chi, which is three and three-quarters grams, and he could tell you the price of a chi in Phnom Penh that morning without looking at a paper. He had been a goldsmith's apprentice in Phnom Penh before the war. In April 1975, when the Khmer Rouge marched everybody out of the city, he had walked past the bank with his mother and seen the money blowing down the boulevard in drifts, riel notes in bundles and loose, against the curbs, in the gutters, and nobody stopping to pick them up. He told that to his son Vibol many times. Paper, he said. They made it nothing in one morning. Four years later he walked out of the fields with two chi of gold sewn into the waistband of his trousers, and gave one chi to a man who knew the

way through the mines to the border and the other to a Thai soldier at the wire at Khao-I-Dang, and that was how he was alive and standing in Massachusetts.

Every other Sunday he had the family to dinner in his house up the hill from the shop, a big two-family with a porch on each floor, which he owned outright, and after the soup he said the same three things to Vibol in front of everybody, the way a monk says a blessing.

Don't think what we have is a lot. It isn't.

What you have, you don't give.

And every day you get a little more.

Then he would lift a gold chain off his own neck and run it through his fingers. *A chain is made one link at a time,* he said, *and it comes apart one link at a time. You never see it go.*

His wife had died in the camp. His sisters were in Long Beach and wrote asking for help with this and that, and he wrote back that business was slow. When the men from the wat came to the shop asking for money to buy a building, so the monks would not have to live in a rented apartment, he took them into the back and gave them tea and said he had given in Cambodia, that everybody had given in Cambodia, the Khmer Rouge had taken everything from everybody, and he was finished giving. The old achar who led the chanting at the wat, a thin man named Moeun who mopped floors at the hospital at night, came once by himself. Sarin gave him tea too. The achar drank it and thanked him and asked for nothing, and that bothered Sarin more than the others had, and he spoke of it for a week.

In the summer of 1994 his heart began to fail. In September, when he could no longer walk to the shop, he called Vibol to the bed and said he would show him where it was.

He did not keep it in a bank. Banks were paper too. He kept it in five places, and he took Vibol to each of them, slowly, leaning on his arm, in an order that he made Vibol repeat back.

Under the floor of the cabinet where the Buddha sat in the front room, where the board lifted if you pressed the left corner.

In the chest freezer in the cellar, at the bottom, in four packages wrapped in white paper and marked with a grease pencil as fish.

In the yard, under the lemongrass that came up every summer by the fence, in a coffee can, two feet down.

In the shop, behind the cinderblock in the back room that was a different gray from the others.

And in the iron pole of the clothesline, which was hollow, and capped, and which nobody would ever look inside because nobody looks inside a clothesline pole.

Don't touch it, he said. *Add to it. Never take.*

He died in October, in the bed, at three in the morning, angry, with his hand around the chain on his neck. The family had the monks to the house and had him cremated and brought the ashes home in an urn, and set his photograph on the cabinet in the front room, above the board that lifted, in a frame of gold.

Vibol took over the shop. He was thirty. He did as he was told.

II. Unlucky

The Acre · 1994–1995

That autumn a crew of Cambodian women, and a few of their husbands, cleaned offices at night out on the highway. There were about forty of them. They rode out together after supper in two vans driven by a man named Heng, who got the contracts and paid the crew in cash every other Friday, and they vacuumed and emptied wastebaskets and scrubbed toilets in the glass buildings of the software companies until four in the morning, and rode home asleep against each other's shoulders. It was not much money, but it came.

In November it stopped coming. Heng said the companies were slow to pay him. In December he said after New Year. All through that winter the crew went out to the buildings every night and worked and came home with nothing, and the women at the Acre began to buy rice on credit at the market and lie awake doing sums.

One of them was Nhem Chann. She was twenty-four, and the man she lived with had gone to Providence in the fall to look for work and had not come back, and by Christmas she knew she was pregnant.

The crew talked about it in the vans. Heng was a cheat, everybody knew Heng was a cheat, but he had been a cheat for four years and had always paid. Something had changed. An old woman named Yeay Pheap said what all of them were thinking. When a crew works and the money doesn't come, there is somebody unlucky in the crew. It happens. You have to find out who.

So they split in two. Twenty went out in one van to the buildings on the north side of the highway, and twenty in the other to the south side, and they worked like that for two weeks. At the end of two weeks a different man came out with an envelope for the north van, and the north van was paid, and the south van was told to wait. Then they changed the people around and did it again. Chann was always in the van that waited.

They did not tell her to her face. Yeay Pheap went to see her in her apartment on a Sunday, with a bag of oranges, and sat with her a long time, and said that the crew was full now, that Heng had too many, and that in her condition she should rest. Chann understood her. The next Friday, when she had been gone from the crew for one week, everybody was paid in full, and Heng paid the back wages too, all of them, in a fat envelope, for reasons nobody ever learned.

After that, nothing Chann did went right. She found work at a laundry and the laundry burned. She found work at a chicken plant in New Hampshire and the ride she had found to get there broke down on Route 3 the first morning, and the second, and on the third morning they gave her place to somebody else. Her rice ran out and the market would not give her credit. She lived that spring on what the wat gave on holy days and on what a woman across the hall left outside her door, and she grew big and tired and frightened.

The baby came at the end of July, at the hospital, in the night. The nurse who handed him to her did not say anything for a moment.

His hands and his feet were not right. His eyes were set at different heights in his face, and his nose was flat to it, and his mouth was open in

the wrong place, up into the lip, so that he could not suck. One ear was a small curled knot of skin. He looked like a clay doll that a child had made in a hurry and dropped. The doctors came, several of them, and talked to her through an interpreter about surgeons in Boston.

Chann looked at him for a long time. Then she put him against her chest, under the hospital gown, against her skin, where she could feel him breathe.

She named him Samnang. It means luck.

III. Samnang

The Lower Highlands · 1995–2004

They operated on him in Boston, three times before he was four. They closed the gap in his lip and the roof of his mouth, and moved one eye, and made his hands into hands that could hold a spoon. But they could not make him into what he would have been, and the neighborhood saw him the way it saw him.

It was strange, the women said. Chann was a good worker. People wanted to give her things. But she could not take him anywhere. When she carried him to the market, the man at the register was out of change, or the line was too long, or the thing she came for was gone from the shelf. When she took him to the wat on holy days the monks blessed him like anyone, but the women in the kitchen found the rice already gone. When she left him home with the woman across the hall and went out by herself, she came home with a job, or a bag of groceries, or a ride.

The children called him Unlucky. In English, so their parents would not understand, but the parents understood.

He was a quiet child. He did not cry when the other children threw things. He went to the special classes at the elementary school and learned to read slowly, and the teachers liked him, because he was careful with everything, careful the way an old man is careful. He never broke anything. When he was five he could add columns of numbers in his head faster than the teacher. When he was six a woman from church brought him a little plastic cash register for Christmas, and he spent the whole

day weighing things on the scale it came with, buttons, beans, a ring of his mother's, and writing the weights down, and Chann watched him and felt cold without knowing why.

Sometimes in his sleep he talked. Not baby talk. He talked like a man, in a man's Khmer, the old Phnom Penh kind, about prices.

In the fall of 2004 he was nine, and Chann had been out of work since the spring, and the rent was three months behind. She sat on the edge of his mattress one morning in October and held his face in her hands. It was the first week of Pchum Ben, the fifteen days when the gates of the underworld stand open and the dead come back to their families hungry, and every Cambodian house in Lowell was cooking.

Kon, she said. *My son. I can't feed you anymore. Since you came, everything we touch falls down. I don't say it's your fault. I say it is what it is.* She put a plastic bag in his hand, the kind from the market. *This is Pchum Ben. Every house is cooking for the dead, and in Pchum Ben nobody turns a hungry one away. Go and eat. Go to the houses. Bring something home if they give it.*

He took the bag. He did not ask why. He went down the stairs one at a time, holding the rail with his good hand, and out into the cold.

IV. The Fourth Room

The Highlands · October 2004

He went up one street and down the next. Some doors he knocked at did not open. At some a woman looked at his face and gave him a sticky-rice cake wrapped in banana leaf and closed the door fast, as if she had paid something off. On Westford Street a grandmother sat him down on her steps and gave him rice and fish soup in a bowl and stood watching him eat with her arms crossed, and when he was finished she took the bowl back inside and washed it twice.

It was past noon when he came to a big two-family house up the hill from Middlesex Street, with a porch on each floor and a chain-link fence and a clothesline in the yard.

He stopped at the gate. He knew it.

He did not know how. He knew the gate stuck at the bottom and you had to lift it. He knew there would be lemongrass by the fence, gone brown now, and there was. He knew the back door would be open in the daytime because the women were cooking, and it was, and the kitchen was full of steam and women and the smell of coconut and banana leaf, a dozen of them, aunts and cousins and neighbors, making num ansorm on every surface for the dead.

He walked in.

He walked through the kitchen, between the women, and not one of them looked at him. He walked through the dining room, where the long table was set with plates covered in plastic wrap and two men were arguing about the Red Sox, and they did not look at him. He walked through the little hall where the coats hung, and a boy his own age came the other way carrying a case of soda and stepped around him without seeing him.

The fourth room was the front room. It was where the Buddha sat on the cabinet, with candles, and incense going in a bowl of sand, and plates of fruit and cakes and a can of Coca-Cola and a pack of Marlboros for the dead, because that was what the dead man had liked. Above it hung a photograph of an old man in a frame of gold. He had a chain around his neck. He was not smiling.

Samnang stood in front of the photograph a long time. Then he went to the cabinet and knelt down and put his hand flat on the floor beside it, on the left corner, the way you put your hand on the head of a dog you know.

Two little children were sitting on the couch in front of the television, a boy of five and a girl of three, Vibol's children, Dara and Malis, eating rice crackers out of a bag. The girl turned around and saw him there at the cabinet with his face, kneeling at her grandfather's altar, and she screamed. Then the boy screamed, because she had. They screamed the way small children do when they have seen a ghost in the house in the season of ghosts, and the women came running from the kitchen with their hands full of banana leaves, and the men came from the dining room.

Vibol's brother-in-law got to him first. Then two cousins.

Get out. Get out of here. What are you, a thief? Get out, you unlucky thing.

They hit him. Not as hard as they could have, but he was nine. They took him by the arms and by the back of his jacket and dragged him back through the hall and the dining room and the kitchen, where the women stood back against the counters to let him go by, and out the back door and down the steps and along the side of the house to the street, where it was trash day, and the green bags were piled at the curb, and they threw him down on top of them.

One of the cousins kicked the plastic market bag after him. A cake fell out of it into the gutter.

The girl was still screaming in the front room. Vibol's wife Sophea had her on her hip. *It's all right,* she said. *It's all right, it's gone, it's only a boy. Look, see. It's Grandpa watching over you.* And she pointed to the photograph.

V. The Achar

Middlesex Street · the same afternoon

Achar Moeun had slept four hours after his shift and gotten up and put on his white shirt, which was the shirt the achar wears, and his good trousers, and walked the eight blocks from his apartment because he did not drive. His grandnephew Rith walked with him. Rith was nineteen and studying to be a nurse at the community college, and he had been walking with the old man since he was fifteen, carrying the bag with the candles and the incense and the books, and asking questions, and getting answers that were usually shorter than the questions.

Moeun was seventy-one. He had been a monk for nine years as a young man in Kampong Cham and had left the robes to marry, and when the Khmer Rouge came they were killing monks and men who could read, so he had stopped being able to read. He had stopped for four years. He herded water buffalo and said yes to everything and let his face go stupid, and he lived, and his wife and his two daughters did not. Afterward, in the camp, he had begun to read again, slowly, like a man learning to walk

on a leg that had been broken. He had led the chanting at the Lowell wat since 1986. At night he mopped the floors at the hospital, the long corridors on the fourth floor where the old people were, and some of the nurses said that patients who were going to die that night often asked for the janitor, and that he would put down the mop and go in and sit with them, and nobody could ever say what he said to them because he said very little, in any language.

That afternoon Kong Vibol had asked him to come to the house to lead the chanting for his father. It was the tenth anniversary.

They turned the corner at the top of the hill and the old man stopped.

There was a boy lying on the trash bags at the curb in front of the Kong house. He was not crying. He was lying there with his eyes open, looking up at the clothesline in the yard, with blood on his lip, which had been sewn together once.

Rith started forward. Moeun put his hand on the young man's arm and held it.

Lok Ta, he's hurt. Why are we standing here?

The old man stood a long moment. The clothesline creaked in the wind. A woman's sweater on it, bright red, turned slowly on its pin.

Ten years ago, Moeun said, *I went to that house and drank tea with Kong Sarin. He gave me tea and nothing else. He had a lot of gold.*

Lok Ta, I know. Everybody knows.

That is Kong Sarin, the old man said. *On the bags.*

Rith looked at him and then at the boy.

He has come home for Pchum Ben, said Moeun, *like the rest of them. They threw him out of his house.* Then he said, in the same plain voice, *Go up and knock. Ask for Vibol. Tell him the achar is here and is waiting in the street.*

VI. Five Places

The Highlands · the same afternoon

VIBOL CAME OUT ONTO THE PORCH IN HIS SOCKS. HE WAS forty now, heavy in the face, with his father's chain around his neck. He saw the achar at the gate and the boy on the trash bags and his relatives

CROWDING OUT BEHIND HIM ONTO THE PORCH AND THE STEPS, and the neighbors coming out onto their own porches, up and down the street, because a crowd draws a crowd and because it was Pchum Ben and everybody was home.

Lok Achar, I'm sorry, come in, come in. There was a boy, a thief, the children were frightened. It's nothing.

Do you know this boy?

Vibol looked at him. He looked at the face. *No.*

He is your father, said the achar. *Kong Sarin.*

Nobody on the porch said anything. A woman behind Vibol made a small sound in her throat. Somebody laughed and stopped.

Vibol went red and then white. He came down the steps in his socks onto the cold walk.

Lok Achar, with respect. With great respect. My father has been dead ten years. His ashes are in my house. I have his photograph. I have taken food to the wat for him every day this week. I'm not a stupid man. He pointed at the boy, who had sat up now on the bags. *That is Nhem Chann's boy from the Acre. Everybody knows him. They call him Unlucky. He has no father, his father went off to Providence.* His voice was shaking. *You come to my house on the tenth anniversary and say this to me in front of the whole street.*

Moeun did not answer him. He turned to the boy.

Sarin, he said. *Show your son the five places.*

The boy got down off the trash bags. He went to the gate and lifted it at the bottom where it stuck, and walked up the walk and up the steps between the relatives, who drew back from him, and in at the front door, and Vibol went after him, and the achar, and Rith, and as many of the rest as could fit into the front room, and the rest stood at the windows.

He knelt at the cabinet below the photograph and pressed the left corner of the floorboard, and it lifted. Under it was a cloth bundle. He did not open it. He looked up at Vibol.

Then he got up and went to the cellar door and down the stairs, and they all went down after him, into the cold cellar with the furnace ticking, to the chest freezer against the wall. He could not lift the lid by himself. Rith lifted it for him. He reached down past the bags of frozen lem-

ongrass and the ice cream and the shrimp to the bottom and came up with a white paper package with a word on it in grease pencil, and held it out. It was heavy. It was not fish.

Then out the back door into the yard. He went to the brown lemongrass by the fence and knelt and began to dig with his hands, with the hands they had made for him in Boston, and Vibol stood over him and watched, and then Vibol knelt down too, in his socks, in the dirt, and dug beside him, and at two feet they hit the lid of the coffee can.

Then the clothesline. The boy stood at the iron pole and put his good hand flat against it, and looked up at the cap, and said nothing. Vibol did not make him do anything more.

And the fifth place was at the shop on Middlesex Street, six blocks away. They walked there, the whole procession of them, the achar and Vibol and the boy and Rith and the relatives and a good part of the street, down the hill in the October afternoon, past the video store and the place that wired money to Battambang, with people coming out of the restaurants to see. Vibol unlocked the shop and they went through to the back room. The boy walked straight to the wall and put his hand on the one cinderblock that was a different gray from the others.

Nobody alive knew of these five places but Kong Vibol. His father had shown him in September of 1994, leaning on his arm, and made him say them back in order, and Vibol had never told his wife. He had done as he was told. He had never taken. Every year he had added.

He turned around from the wall. He looked down at the boy for a long time, at the eyes set at their different heights, the knotted ear, the mended lip, the jacket with the trash smell on it. Something went out of his face, all at once, the way air goes out of a room when a door opens.

Pa, he said.

He got down on his knees on the concrete floor of the back room. He did it the way you kneel to a monk, three times, with his palms together and his forehead to the floor. Then he turned on his knees and did it a fourth time to the old achar, who stood in the door of the back room in his white shirt with the bag of candles Rith had given him to hold.

The achar waited until Vibol was finished. Then he said it, quietly, in the Pali first, the way he would have chanted it, and then in Khmer. Rith looked it up that night in the old English translation in the college library, because English was the language he thought in, and copied it out, and kept it.

> *That even of which a man thinks 'this is mine' is left behind by death: knowing this, let not the wise (man) turn himself to worldliness (while being my) follower. As a man awakened does not see what he has met with in his sleep, so also he does not see the beloved person that has passed away and is dead.*
>
> *— Sutta Nipāta 806–807 (Jarāsutta), tr. V. Fausbøll*

Vibol was still on his knees. *What do I do, Lok Ta,* he said. *Tell me what to do with it.*

It isn't his, said the achar. *He has been showing you that for nine years. It isn't yours either.* He looked at the gray cinderblock. *You'll know.*

VII. Bay Ben

The wat · the last morning of Pchum Ben

Before light on the fifteenth day the yard of the wat was full. It was cold, and people stood in their coats over their good clothes, the old women in white, with their breath showing, and the windows of the building lit yellow behind them, and the monks chanting inside where it was warm. Each family had brought a bowl of bay ben, the little balls of sticky rice mixed with sesame and beans, and before the sun came up they walked around the building three times in the dark and threw them out into the yard and the grass and the parking lot, a handful at a time, for the dead who had no family to feed them. The old women said that was why it was done before light, because the hungry ones are ashamed to be seen.

Achar Moeun stood on the steps in his white shirt and led them. He had come straight from the hospital. There was still floor wax on his shoes.

Kong Vibol walked the circle with his wife and his children. Behind him walked Nhem Chann, whom he had gone to see on the Thursday in the Acre, and had sat with in her kitchen for two hours, and had given the rent and more than the rent and a job in the shop, which she would start on Monday. Between them walked the boy, in a new jacket, with a bowl of his own.

The neighbors watched them go around. People talked, the way people do. It was already a story by then, and the story was already growing, the way they do; by Christmas there were people in Lynn and Long Beach who would swear that the boy had walked into the shop and opened the wall with his bare hand, and that the gold behind it had turned to rice. It hadn't. It was gold. Over the next year Vibol took it out, all five places of it, and paid for the new roof on the wat, and sent money to his aunts in Long Beach, and to a village outside Battambang that his father had not written to in thirty years, and paid for the surgeons in Boston to do one more operation, which was the one the boy had wanted most, on his ear. Some of it he kept. He was not a saint. But he never again put any of it in the ground.

That morning, though, nobody knew any of that yet. They only went around in the dark, three times, throwing rice.

On the third time around the boy stopped at the corner of the building, where the light from the windows did not reach. He took a ball of rice out of his bowl and turned it in his fingers, and then he did not throw it. He ate it, standing there, the way a hungry one would, slowly, all of it.

Then he took another out of the bowl, and leaned back, and threw it as far as he could into the dark.

Background

The verse

> *"These sons belong to me, and this wealth belongs to me," with such thoughts a fool is tormented. He himself does not belong to himself; how much less sons and wealth?*
>
> Dhammapada 62, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Ānanda is a rich man of Sāvatthī with eight hundred million in treasure, who warns his son Mūlasiri every fortnight never to think it a large sum, never to give anything away, and always to get more. He shows his son his five great stores of treasure and dies in his avarice. He is reborn in a village of outcastes who hire themselves out as a crew; from the day he is conceived the crew is paid nothing, until they search out the unlucky one and drive his mother away. The child is born misshapen, and when he is old enough his mother puts a bowl in his hand and sends him to beg. He wanders into his old house, passes through three rooms unseen, frightens his grandchildren in the fourth, and is beaten and thrown on the dust-heap. The Buddha, passing with Ānanda the Elder, tells Mūlasiri the beggar is his father, and when the son will not believe it, has the beggar point out the five buried stores. Read the full commentary story, or about the Dhammapada and its commentary. The verse the achar speaks comes from the Sutta Nipāta, an early Pali collection that Viggo Fausbøll translated in 1881.

Lowell, Massachusetts

Lowell, 2004

Under the Khmer Rouge, from 1975 to 1979, Cambodia's cities were emptied, banks were raided and the currency and its records were burned, and something like a fifth to a quarter of the population died. Survivors who reached the Thai border after the regime fell came through camps such as Khao-I-Dang, opened in November 1979, and many were resettled in the United States. From the mid-1980s they settled in Lowell, Massachusetts, the old mill city on the Merrimack, opening dozens of small

businesses; by 2010 Lowell had the highest proportion of Cambodian residents of any city in the country. More on the Cambodian genocide and on Cambodian Americans.

Pchum Ben is a fifteen-day festival at the end of the rains retreat, in September or October, when the gates of the underworld are said to open and the dead return to their families. Cambodians honor up to seven generations of ancestors with food brought to the monks, and many throw balls of sticky rice into the temple grounds for the wandering dead. An achar is a layman, often a former monk, who serves as master of ceremonies in the temple's rites. In Cambodia gold is still bought and sold by the *chi* of 3.75 grams.

After the story of the rich man Ānanda from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 62). The original. Scripture from the Sutta Nipāta, tr. V. Fausbøll (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 10, 1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.4

Welcome to Our Table

Sit down and feed, and welcome to our table.
— Shakespeare, As You Like It, II.vii

This is the way I had it, under the hill at Natchez.

I. The Trumpet

Natchez-Under-the-Hill, Mississippi · February 1836

Natchez was two towns then. The one on the bluff had the brick houses and the banks. The one under the bluff was a shelf of mud between the hill and the river, a single street called Silver Street and whatever hung off it: grog shops, dance houses, boatmen's lodgings, and at the landing an acre of flatboats tied gunwale to gunwale. A mile back of the bluff, at the Forks of the Road, the traders were selling people that winter by the hundred, and the cotton those people were bought to pick came down Silver Street on drays and went out by the same landing.

Tobe Finch and Dab Harker had come down the river in the fall as hands on a flour boat out of Cincinnati. Tobe was sixteen and Dab a year older. The cholera of thirty-two had made orphans of them both, and the township had bound them out, Tobe and his small brother Pim to a tanner and Dab to a man who made rope. They had run from their indentures the same week. There was a notice out for each of them in a Cincinnati paper, offering six cents reward, which came to a quarter of a cent less than one picayune a head.

They lived by their fingers. Dab was the hand and Tobe was the stall. Tobe went ahead into a crowd and stopped short, or stumbled, or asked a man the way to the ferry, and while the man looked at Tobe, two of Dab's fingers were in his pocket. Poor people on the river carried their small

money tied in a knot, in the corner of a handkerchief or the tail of a shirt. Dab could have a knot open with one hand before its owner had finished answering about the ferry. He was proud of that. They kept two lean-tos side by side on the mud below Silver Street, Tobe and Pim in one, and in the other Dab and a girl of fifteen named Sukey whom he called his wife.

On a wet evening in February a trumpet blew on the river. A long low house was coming in to the landing on a flatboat hull, a hundred feet of it, with a flag at the bow that said THEATRE and a man on the roof with the trumpet. It was the Fenno family, eleven of them counting sons' wives, who had left Pittsburgh on the fall rise and played every landing down two rivers. An English family named Chapman had been first on the water with a theatre boat, and the Fennos did as the Chapmans did. Four bits a head, or a peck of anything that could be eaten. That night, *As You Like It*.

Two hundred people on benches in the dark, Dab said, *all looking the same way.*

II. The Banquet

Aboard the Floating Theatre · that night

THEY GOT IN BY THE STERN WHILE THE TRUMPET WAS STILL going. The room was as narrow as a covered bridge. There were plank benches, and a row of tallow candles in tin reflectors across the front of a stage no bigger than a wagon bed. The benches were full of Kentucky boatmen, draymen, steamboat hands, clerks down from the bluff, men with rifles on their way to Texas, and women from the dance houses. At the back by the door, where colored people were let to stand, there were hack drivers and market women with their passes.

The plan was the usual one. When the place was full and the play well along, Tobe would go up the gangway between the benches and block it, and Dab would come along behind him through the standing people, working.

Tobe got as far as the middle of the gangway. On the stage an old servant had lain down in a forest that was painted on a bedsheet, saying that

he could go no further, that he was dying for food. Tobe had Pim at home. He stopped to hear what became of the old man, and he never went any further up the gangway that night.

What became of him was this. A duke who had been turned out of his own country was sitting down to supper in the forest with his people. The supper was real. It was the Fennos' own, a pone and a fried catfish and a dish of yams laid out on a plank, because the company could not afford to set a table twice in one evening. Before any of them had touched it, the old servant's young master ran in among them with a sword in his hand.

> *ORLANDO. Forbear, and eat no more.*
>
> *DUKE SENIOR. What would you have? Your gentleness shall force*
> *More than your force move us to gentleness.*
>
> *ORLANDO. I almost die for food, and let me have it.*
>
> *DUKE SENIOR. Sit down and feed, and welcome to our table.*
>
> *— Shakespeare, As You Like It, II.vii*

The young man with the sword did not know what to do then. Tobe did not either. He had been a thief for two years, and in that time he had been chased and cuffed, and locked a night in a smokehouse, and preached at once from the tail of a wagon. Nobody had ever answered him like that. He had not known there was such an answer. The young man said he had thought all things were savage here. He said, *I blush and hide my sword,* and went to carry in the old man on his back, and the Duke would not let anybody eat until the two of them had come.

Tobe stood in the gangway through the rest of it, with boatmen cursing him to sit down. He heard the clown, too. The clown was old Mrs. Fenno in a coat made all of patches. Her sons were wanted for the lovers and the wrestler, so she played the fools, and it was said along the river that there was no better one between Pittsburgh and the Balize.

Dab waited at the back for a stall who did not come. Then he worked by himself, as well as he could with nobody to draw eyes. By the door stood an old Black drayman who hired his own time from his master and

had his week's small money knotted in the tail of his shirt. Dab had the knot open and shut again while the old man was laughing at the clown.

On the bank afterward he opened his hand under a pine-knot torch. Five picayunes.

Where were you?

I was hearing it, Tobe said.

III. The Cold Hearth

Below Silver Street · the next day

FIVE PICAYUNES BOUGHT MEAL AND A CATFISH AND A TWIST OF coffee. By noon there was a fire in front of Dab's lean-to, and Sukey had the fish in the skillet and dodgers in the ashes.

There was no fire in front of the other. Tobe had been at the landing since daylight asking for work. The cotton there was rolled by men whose masters were paid for them, and nobody would give a boy a picayune to do what he already owned a man to do. A storekeeper let him sweep and then said he had not asked him to. He had walked among a hundred pockets that morning with his hands at his sides, and he could not have told anyone why, only that the thing was finished. Pim sat on the sill of the lean-to with his knees up, watching Sukey's skillet.

Here he is, Dab said. *Here's the scholar. He went to the play and got so wise he can't find his dinner.*

Don't it smell good, Solomon? said Sukey. *You're so almighty wise now, how is it there's nothing cooking at your house?*

Dab laughed until he had to put down his cup. He was the one with fish in the skillet, and it stood to reason that he was the one with sense.

Tobe looked at him across the two yards of mud. He thought: he does not know. He is as big a fool as I was the day before yesterday, and he takes himself for the cleverest man under the hill, and that is all that ails him. I didn't know it of myself either, until last night.

He took Pim by the hand and went down to the boat.

IV. The Coat of Patches

Aboard the Floating Theatre · that afternoon

By day the theatre was a house like any other. There was washing on the roof. One of the sons was painting a bedsheet into a palace. Old Mr. Fenno, who was the Duke at night, was the cook by day, and he had the plank set up on the stage and was laying dinner on it for eleven. Mrs. Fenno sat on the edge of the stage with the clown's coat across her knees, sewing a red patch over a worn green one.

It was said of her that off the stage she did not use six words in a day, and that when she did speak it was a line out of some play if she could find one to fit.

Tobe stood in the gangway where he had stood the night before, holding his brother's hand, and told her. He told her that he and another had come aboard to rob her house, and what his part was to have been, and that he had not done it because he was hearing the play. He told her about the five picayunes and whose they were. He told her about the cold hearth, and what Dab and Sukey had said to him across the mud. *He says I've got so wise I can't get my dinner. He thinks it, too.*

Mrs. Fenno bit off her thread. She looked at him a good while, and then at the small boy. Then she gave him the line, in the clown's voice, which was her own voice.

> *The fool doth think he is wise, but the wise man knows himself to be a fool.*
>
> *— Shakespeare, As You Like It, V.i*

She shook out the coat and held it up to the light from the door to see how the new patch sat. Then she moved along the edge of the stage to make room.

Old Mr. Fenno had counted the two of them already. He set down two more tin plates on the plank and said the other line, the one he said every night to a young man with a sword.

Sit down and feed, and welcome to our table.

They sat down. The sons and the sons' wives came in from the roof and the river and sat down too, and nobody at that table asked the boys a question until the fish was gone.

Tobe carried wood and water for the Fennos until dark, and Mr. Fenno paid him a picayune. He took out his handkerchief and tied the coin into the corner of it. It took him three tries. He had helped open a thousand knots, and he had never before had anything to tie in one.

Background

The verse

> *The fool who knows his foolishness, is wise at least so far. But a fool who thinks himself wise, he is called a fool indeed.*
>
> Dhammapada 63, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary two thieves, close companions, go with a great crowd to the Jetavana monastery where the Buddha is teaching. They are "knot-breakers," pickpockets who undo the knots in which people tie up their coins. One of them listens and is changed; the other finds five small coins tied in the hem of a man's garment and takes them. The next day food is cooked as usual in the thief's house and none in his friend's, and the thief and his wife jeer at the friend for being so wise that he cannot get a meal. He reflects that the man takes himself for wise only because he is a fool, goes with his family to the Buddha and tells him, and the Buddha speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.

Natchez-Under-the-Hill, Mississippi

Natchez-Under-the-Hill and the theatre boats, 1836

Natchez-Under-the-Hill was the landing below the bluff at Natchez, known up and down the Mississippi for its gambling rooms, dance houses and boatmen; a traveler said you could see an acre of flatboats lying there at any time. In July 1835 a mob at Vicksburg, upriver, hanged five gamblers, and committees in other river towns moved against theirs. Natchez in those years was also one of the great markets of the domestic slave trade, centered on the Forks of the Road east of town. Some enslaved men in the river towns, draymen among them, were allowed to hire their own time and keep what they earned above a fixed payment to their owners. The smallest coin that passed on the lower river was the picayune, the Spanish half-real, worth six and a quarter cents. Northern masters did advertise for runaway apprentices at a derisive "six cents reward." In February 1836 volunteers for the war in Texas were passing down the river.

The first American showboat was the Floating Theatre built at Pittsburgh in 1831 by the English actor William Chapman, who with his family of nine drifted down the Ohio and Mississippi each season, playing at the landings for fifty cents or its worth in produce, and sold the boat at New Orleans. The Fennos and their boat are invented after that pattern. *As You Like It* had long been played on American stages. The lines here are from Act II, scene vii, where the starving Orlando bursts in on the banished Duke's supper, and from Act V, scene i, where the clown Touchstone quotes "a saying" to a country fellow who has just told him, "Ay, sir, I have a pretty wit."

After the story of the thieves who broke their bonds from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 63). The original. Lines from Shakespeare's *As You Like It*. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

5.5

The Iron Ladle

I cannot teach it to my son; nor can he learn it from me.
— Chuang Tzŭ, ch. XIII, tr. Herbert A. Giles (1889)

Wǒ shì zhème tīngshuō de, at the back door on 104th Street.

I. The Photograph

Broadway at 104th Street, Manhattan · autumn 1974

The Xiang Garden had nineteen tables, a red lacquer screen to hide the kitchen door, and a porcelain Laughing Buddha beside the register with his belly rubbed pale by two years of customers on their way out. Before that it had been a luncheonette, and before that a Cuban-Chinese place that sold fried plantains with the pork fried rice, and the old counter stools were still bolted to the floor along one wall where nobody had been able to get them up.

Zeng Shifu did the cooking. He was sixty-six. He had been a scullery boy in a restaurant in Changsha that burned with the rest of the city in 1938, and a cook for an infantry division all through the war, and he had crossed to Taiwan in 1949 with the division and its stoves, and for twenty years he had cooked at a restaurant off Zhongshan North Road in Taipei where the generals ate. In 1971 a cousin brought him over. He wore a sleeveless undershirt and a paper hat and cloth slippers, and he did not come out of the kitchen, ever, for anybody.

Yao Delu came out of the kitchen for everybody. He was from the same county as Zeng and had been at his elbow since 1940, when the division took him on to wash pots, and when Zeng crossed the strait Yao crossed with him, and when Zeng came to New York Yao came the next year on the same cousin's papers. He owned a tenth of the restaurant. He stood at

the door in a white cook's jacket with a high collar, ironed, and seated people, and told them about Hunan, and recommended the smoked pork with leeks and the Dong'an chicken and, to anybody who seemed brave, the whole fish with chopped chilies. He told them Hunan food was not like the Cantonese food they knew from Chinatown. It was hot, and sour, and smoked, and honest. Chairman Mao was from Hunan, he told them, and he said it as though Mao had been a nephew who had disappointed everybody.

Since President Nixon had gone to Peking, Americans wanted to eat what was eaten there, and anything from China was in the newspapers. In the spring a critic came three times without saying who she was and wrote two columns about the Xiang Garden, and a photographer came to take a picture of the chef. Zeng would not come out of the kitchen. He would not come out for Chiang Kai-shek and he did not come out for a newspaper. So Yao went back and stood beside the big burner with the iron ladle in his hand, in his white jacket, smiling, and that was the photograph. It hung in the front window now in a dime-store frame, a little yellowed by the sun: *Master of Hunan cooking at the Xiang Garden.*

On the slow nights, after Zeng had gone home to his room on Amsterdam Avenue, Yao went back to the kitchen and sat in Zeng's chair.

It was a bamboo armchair, the only one in the kitchen, and it stood by the back door where the air came in from the alley. Zeng sat in it between orders in the afternoon and smoked Pall Malls and said nothing. Nobody else sat in it. It was not a rule; nobody had ever said anything; the dishwashers and the young cooks just didn't. But after ten o'clock Yao sat in it, with his tea in a jam jar, and his white jacket unbuttoned at the throat, and told the dishwashers about the war.

II. The Chair

The kitchen · a Monday night in November

THE THREE YOUNG COOKS CAME IN THE BACK WAY, AS COOKS do, a little after ten.

They worked at a new Szechuan place on Second Avenue in the Fifties, and Monday was their night off, and they had come all the way uptown on the subway to see the master of Hunan cooking. Kao was from Taichung and had cooked in Taipei. Wong was from Hong Kong and spoke Cantonese and English and not much Mandarin. Lin was nineteen and the youngest and had been in New York four months, and he had cut the photograph out of the newspaper and kept it in his wallet.

Through the screen door they saw the old man in the white jacket in the bamboo chair by the back door, and Lin knew him from the picture. They came in and bowed a little, and Kao said their names and where they worked, and said they had come to learn.

Yao was delighted. He sent the dishwasher for more tea. He asked them where their families were from, and told them about the burning of Changsha, which he had not seen, and about the generals in Taipei, and which of them had liked his food very salty.

Kao asked about the Dong'an chicken. How did Shifu balance the five flavors in it? It was the sourness that people talked about.

Balance, said Yao. *Yes. That is the whole secret of Hunan cooking. You have to feel it.*

Which vinegar did Shifu use? Rice vinegar or black?

Yao said black vinegar, from Zhenjiang, the best. Kao looked at Wong. Lin, who had eaten the Dong'an chicken at the front table an hour before and could still taste it, said nothing.

Wong asked in English how long the pork was smoked, and over what. Tea leaves? Rice husks? Camphor wood, the way they did it in Sichuan?

Long time, said Yao in English. *Very long time. Patience.* He laughed and slapped his knee.

Kao asked about huohou, the timing of the fire, for the chicken: how hot the wok, how long, when the chilies went in, when the ginger. He asked about the knife work, how fine the ginger was cut. He asked whether Shifu blanched the chicken first or poached it whole. Yao answered all of it. He answered it the way the photograph answered it, smiling and holding the ladle, and none of it was anything.

At last Lin asked him, very politely, to name the five flavors.

Yao said sour, and sweet, and salty, and hot. He stopped. He drank some tea. *And fragrant,* he said.

Wong laughed out loud. Kao got up. Yao laughed too, because they were laughing, and offered them more tea, and they said they had to catch the train.

Out in the alley among the garbage cans Kao lit a cigarette and swore. *Thirty years,* he said. *Thirty years at the master's elbow, in the master's chair, in the master's picture in the newspaper, and he can't name the five flavors. Bitter. He forgot bitter.*

Maybe he's not the master, said Lin.

Then what is he?

Lin didn't know. He had a feeling, the way you have a feeling about a sauce before you taste it, that they had come in the wrong door.

III. The Ladle

The same kitchen · Tuesday, before the lunch rush

Kao would not go back. Wong and Lin went back the next morning at eleven, before their own shift, and came in by the alley again, and this time the bamboo chair was empty, and an old man in an undershirt and a paper hat was standing at the big burner with his back to them, lighting it with a twist of newspaper.

It went up with a roar, a ring of blue jets as wide as a dinner plate, and he set the wok on it, and while it heated he turned around and looked at them.

Lin told him. He told it straight, the way it had happened, and he felt bad telling it, because the old man in the white jacket had given them tea. Wong put in a word here and there in English. They had come to learn from the master of Hunan cooking. The man in the picture could not tell them which vinegar. He could not tell them how the pork was smoked. He could not name the five flavors. He had forgotten bitter. How could a man live thirty years beside the master and not know that?

Zeng listened to the end. Then he laughed, a short laugh that turned into a cough, and turned back to the wok, and poured in oil, and swirled

it, and did not say anything for a while. Out front somebody was vacuuming. A delivery boy came in with a crate of scallions and went out.

When he spoke it was in Mandarin, with a Hunan accent so thick that Wong understood almost none of it, and Lin, standing at his shoulder, put it into English as he went. It was an old story; Lin had read it in school in Taiwan and never thought of it since. A duke was reading in his hall, and a wheelwright working below put down his tools and asked what the duke was reading. The words of the sages, said the duke. And are the sages alive? No, they are dead. Then what you are reading is the dregs. The duke was angry and told him to explain himself or die. And the wheelwright said:

> *In making a wheel, if you work too slowly, you can't make it firm; if you work too fast, the spokes won't fit in. You must go neither too slowly nor too fast. There must be co-ordination of mind and hand. Words cannot explain what it is, but there is some mysterious art herein. I cannot teach it to my son; nor can he learn it from me.*
>
> *— Chuang Tzŭ, ch. XIII, tr. Herbert A. Giles (1889)*

Zeng threw a handful of ginger into the oil, and it hissed. Then he reached up without looking and took the iron ladle down from its hook over the stove. It was a cook's ladle, a shallow bowl on a long handle, black, worn bright along one side of the rim where it had scraped ten thousand woks.

I brought this from Taipei, he said. *Twenty-three years. It has been in every pot. It has been in every Dong'an chicken I ever made.* He held it out toward the two young men, handle first, as if they might want to interview it. *Ask it which vinegar.*

Wong understood that much without Lin.

Zeng put the chicken in, and the chilies, and the Sichuan pepper, and worked the ladle under it and over it, and the fire came up around the wok, and the kitchen filled with a smell that went straight to the back of the throat and made both of them cough. He added the vinegar. Rice vinegar, Lin saw, pale. He tossed it twice and then dipped the ladle in and

lifted out a little of the sauce, and held the ladle out again, this time bowl first.

Taste, he said.

Lin tasted. It was sour first and then hot and then something under both of them that he had no word for, and then the hot again, and his eyes ran. He stood there with his mouth open, breathing out through it. He had been going to ask a question, he could not remember what. Wong took the ladle out of his hand and tasted, and shut his eyes.

Zeng took the ladle back and wiped it on his apron and hung it on its hook.

Don't blame Lao Yao, he said. *He washed my pots for nine years in the war. Nobody ever washed pots better. Now go to work, you'll be late.*

• • •

Lin worked at the Xiang Garden from the next spring until Zeng died in 1981, and afterward he had restaurants of his own, in Flushing and later in New Jersey, and he never wrote anything down for anybody. When young cooks came in the back door to ask him things, he gave them a spoon.

But that Tuesday, going out through the dining room on the way to the train, he and Wong passed Yao at the front, in his white jacket, buttoned to the throat and freshly ironed, dusting the Laughing Buddha by the register with a feather duster. He waved to them with it. A party of four from Columbia had come in early for lunch, and he was seating them by the window, under his own picture, and telling them that the whole secret of Hunan cooking was balance.

Background

The verse

> *If a fool be associated with a wise man even all his life, he will perceive the truth as little as a spoon perceives the taste of soup.*
>
> Dhammapada 64, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Udāyī lives with the Buddha at Jetavana, and whenever the great elders leave the Dhamma Hall he goes in and sits in the preacher's seat. Some visiting monks see him there, take him for a learned elder, and question him about the aggregates, the elements and the sense-spheres. He knows nothing about any of it. Scornful, they ask what such a monk is doing in the same monastery as the Buddha and report him. The Buddha answers with this verse: a fool can wait on the wise for a lifetime and learn the Dhamma no more than a spoon learns the taste of the curry. At the end of it the visiting monks themselves are freed. The next verse in the Dhammapada (65) completes the image: the intelligent man who sits with the wise for a moment knows the truth as the tongue knows the taste of soup. Read the full commentary story, or about the *Zhuangzi*, the Daoist book that holds the wheelwright's story.

Upper West Side, Manhattan, New York

New York, 1974

Until the 1960s nearly all Chinese food in the United States was Cantonese, cooked by and for families from the Pearl River delta. After the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 opened the country to new arrivals, and especially after President Nixon's visit to China in 1972, New York discovered Sichuan and Hunan cooking, with its chilies, sourness and smoked and cured meats. Many of the new cooks and owners came by way of Taiwan, where mainland soldiers and officials who had retreated with the Nationalists in 1949 had opened restaurants serving their home provinces' food. The best known of them, the Hunanese chef Peng Chang-kuei, had cooked official banquets in Taipei and opened a restaurant on East 44th Street around 1973, and the dish he is credited with, General Tso's chicken, became the most famous Hunan dish in America; when Peng later opened a restaurant in Hunan itself, the locals found it too sweet.

Taiwanese-run restaurants spread up and down Manhattan in the following years; one of the first of the Szechuan chains opened at Broadway and 97th Street in 1976, with Taiwanese students from Columbia driving its deliveries. Zeng Shifu's first res-

taurant burned in the Changsha fire of November 1938, set by Nationalist officials so that the advancing Japanese would find nothing; more than 30,000 people died and about nine-tenths of the city's buildings burned.

After the story of the Elder Udāyī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 64). The original. Scripture from *Chuang Tzŭ: Mystic, Moralist, and Social Reformer*, tr. Herbert A. Giles (1889). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.6

The Silk-Cotton Trees

> *O taste, and see that the Lord is sweet: blessed is the man that hopeth in him.*
> *— Psalm 33:9*

Así lo oí contar, on the east bank of the Ozama.

I. Martinmas

The Ozama River, Hispaniola · the eleventh of November, 1510

There were thirty of them, from Trujillo and Cáceres and the villages between, sons of houses that had more name than land. They had come out in the spring fleet with their swords and their fathers' debts. In the summer the governor's men had given each of them a share of Indians, so many heads written down beside each name, and they had sent those Indians up to the streams of the Cibao to wash gold. In the autumn the gold came down to the smelting house at Concepción. When the King's fifth had been taken out, what was left went into one leather purse, because they had come out together and meant to stay together. Diego de Hinojosa wore it around his neck under his shirt.

On Saint Martin's day they crossed the river from the stone city to the east bank and held a matanza under the ceibas, the way their fathers did at home. In Extremadura every house killed its pig at Martinmas. Here nobody needed to keep a pig. The pigs the Admiral had let loose on the island seventeen years before had gone wild in the forest by the thousand, and that morning the dogs had run one down in the cane brakes and held it by the ears until Alonso Golfín came up with the knife. Now it hung from a low limb of the biggest ceiba, opened and smoking, and the Indians the young men had brought down from the mines to serve

them were turning the meat over a fire of guava wood. There was cassava bread, and fish from the river, and two jars of wine from Seville that had cost more than a horse.

The ceibas stood along the bank like the pillars of a church, grey and smooth, with roots that came out of the ground higher than a man's waist and ran off in walls among the grass. The Indians would not cut them. In the dry season, they said, the pods split and the cotton came down like snow, and the young men from Cáceres, who had never seen the cotton, said they would believe it when they saw it.

Gonzalo de Chaves was the only one who had brought a woman. She was one of the Indians written down beside his name, and he called her Catalina. Her own name nobody had asked. She sat a little way off from him on a root of the ceiba and did not eat.

By the middle of the afternoon the wine was gone and the thirty were asleep in the shade with their mouths open, and the Indians had gone down to the water. When Diego de Hinojosa woke up, his shirt was open and the purse was gone, and so was she.

They went after her the way they went after anything on that island, with the dogs. There were two alanos, brindled, with heads like anvils. The dogs took the trail up the river through the cane, the thirty running behind them with their swords out and the wine still in their legs, shouting the name Gonzalo had given her, as if she would answer to it. The trail went a long way up the bank and then into a grove of ceibas older than the ones they had left, and there it stopped.

A man was sitting there on a root, in the white habit and black cape of the friars who had come to the city in September, the ones who lived in a house of straw and ate nothing anybody could see. He had a basket of palm leaves on his knees and he was mending it. The two dogs ran up to him and lay down.

Brother, said Gonzalo, out of breath. *Did a woman come by here? An Indian. She has something of ours.*

The friar looked up. He was old, with big red hands and a face like a field after harvest, and when he spoke it was in the Spanish of their own country, the Spanish of the pig fairs at Trujillo.

Sons, he said, *what do you think? Which would be better for you, to go looking for a woman, or to go looking for yourselves?*

Nobody answered him. One of them laughed and stopped.

Ourselves, said Diego de Hinojosa at last, because somebody had to say something.

Then sit down, said the friar, *and I will tell you what I know.*

II. The Straw House

Santo Domingo and the Pearl Coast · 1510–1515

His name was Fray Gil. He was not a priest. He was a lay brother, which meant he cooked for the others and swept and begged in the streets of the city with a basket, and before that, he told them, he had kept pigs for the Count's people on the oak plains outside Trujillo until he was twenty-six, and then he had gone to the war at Granada, and then to the friars at Salamanca. He sat with them under the ceibas until it was dark. What he said they could not afterward agree on. Some of them said he talked about the purse, and some about their mothers, and some about the Indians in the mines, and some about nothing at all. All thirty agreed that it had been very simple, and that it had not taken long, and that at the end of it he had put the basket down and said, *Come,* and they had come.

They left the dogs at the ford. In the morning, in the friars' straw house at the edge of the city, there were thirty white habits lying folded on the dirt floor, of good Castilian wool, though the friars had brought nothing from Spain but what they wore, and no ship had come in since August. Nobody in the house would say where they had come from. The thirty put them on.

They sent their papers back to the governor's house and gave up their Indians. The city laughed at them for a month and then forgot them. They lived the way the friars lived, in wool in that heat, on cassava and boiled greens, with no meat in the house, because the Rule of the Order forbade it there. Thirty young men raised on pork. They slept on boards. They begged the city with baskets. In their second Advent they stood at

the back of the church when Fray Antonio de Montesinos preached the sermon that set the whole island against the friars, and they were not surprised by anything in it. Then they went out. They walked to the mining camps and the Indian towns along the Cibao and lived on what was given them, which was not much. Some of them went over the water to the Pearl Coast and lived in a hut of palm thatch among people whose language they had to learn, and all of them came back, thinner, with fever in their bones.

It was five years before all of them were in the city again at the same time.

III. Martinmas Again

The east bank of the Ozama · the eleventh of November, 1515

The year before, the King's men had counted the Indians of the island again so that they could divide them again, and found hardly more than half the number of the count seven years before. In the city they were saying the island would have to be filled with Indians from somewhere else, or with Africans, or the mines would stop.

On Saint Martin's day Fray Gil took the thirty across the river to the old ceibas and sat them down among the roots, in their habits, brown now and patched with every color of cloth the island had. Across the water the city was killing its pigs. They could hear it from where they sat. They could smell the singeing.

He let them listen a while. Then he asked them a question, the way he had the first time.

Sons. Which is more, the water in the sea between here and Sanlúcar, or the blood that has run out on the ground since the first Martinmas?

Some of them had crossed that sea three times now. Nobody answered for a while. Then Diego de Hinojosa said, *The blood, Brother.*

Yes, said Fray Gil. *Count. Every house in Castile, every November, one pig, since before the Moors. Every ox and every sheep and every hen. Every man at Granada, ours and theirs. Count this island, since the Admiral. Count what you washed out of the Cibao, Diego, and what it cost. You cannot find where it*

starts. Nobody can. Look as far back as you like, there is somebody holding the rope and somebody at the end of it, and before that the same, and before that the same.

Across the river a pig screamed and stopped.

> *Idcirco unus interitus est hominis et jumentorum, et aequa utriusque conditio.*
>
> *Therefore the death of man, and of beasts is one, and the condition of them both is equal: as man dieth, so they also die: all things breathe alike, and man hath nothing more than beast: all things are subject to vanity.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 3:19*

And he gave them the other one, which every friar in the straw house knew by heart that year, because it was the verse that had turned the cleric Bartolomé de las Casas out of his own Indians in Cuba the year before.

> *The bread of the needy, is the life of the poor: he that defraudeth them thereof, is a man of blood. He that taketh away the bread gotten by sweat, is like him that killeth his neighbour. He that sheddeth blood, and he that defraudeth the labourer of his hire, are brothers.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 34:25–27*

Then he took a cake of cassava out of his sleeve and broke it in pieces, and took a twist of salt out of the other sleeve and salted every piece, and gave each of them one.

O taste, and see, he said.

They ate. What happened to the thirty under the ceibas then, Alonso Golfín put best, when he was old. It was like the salt, he said. You do not have to be told about salt. You do not have to think about it, or be taught it by a master at Salamanca. It is on your tongue and you know it, all of it, at once, and you could not afterward not know it if you tried. Before they got up off the roots of the ceiba, every one of them had tasted it.

IV. Every Pig

The straw house · that winter

AFTERWARD THE FRIARS TALKED ABOUT IT IN THE HOUSE. THEY said it had taken Fray Gil one afternoon to give those thirty what most men did not get in fifty years of prayer, and a young friar from Burgos said that it was not just, and that it did not seem to him to follow the order of grace as he had been taught it.

Fray Gil was peeling yuca at the table. He said it was not one afternoon.

Then he told them a story his grandmother had told him on the oak plains, which had happened, she said, in her grandmother's time, in a village outside Trujillo. An old widow there had found two piglets in a ditch where their mother had left them, and raised them in her house like children, and called the big one Snout and the little one Little Snout. When they were fat, men came every autumn to buy them, and every autumn she said, *Would you sell your own children to be eaten?* One Martinmas thirty young men of the village, drunk since morning, came to her door with money and ropes. She would not sell. So they gave her wine until she would, and she said, *Not the big one. Take the little one.* And she filled the trough by the door and called him, which she had never done before, because she always called the big one first.

Little Snout looked out and saw the full trough and the old woman standing by it and thirty men with ropes in their hands, and he went back into the house shaking. And Snout, the big one, the one she always called first, said to him: *Brother, this is what she fed us for. Eat. Do not be afraid.* And then he began to preach to them all, the pig did, the old woman said, in a voice that carried to every house in the village, about what it is to die well and what it is to be clean. The thirty young men dropped their ropes. They stood in the mud with their hats off until he had finished, and went and made their confessions that same night, and kept the commandments all their lives, and not one of them ever again could eat pork at Martinmas without remembering.

Every pig has its Martinmas, said Fray Gil. *My grandmother always said that at the end. That is all the story there is.* He put down the knife. *I always thought those thirty were the same as these.*

The young friar from Burgos said that was not a doctrine. Fray Gil said no, it was a pig.

V. The Cotton

The Ozama · March 1516

THE PURSE WAS NEVER FOUND, AND NEITHER WAS SHE. Gonzalo de Chaves asked about her among the Indians for a long time, in the language he had learned on the Pearl Coast, and once a fisherman told him that there was a woman in the mountains of the Bahoruco, where the King's men did not go, who had come out of the east a long time before with a purse of gold, and had walked into a river with it and come out without it. Gonzalo did not know if that was her. He went on asking.

In March, in the dry season, he crossed the Ozama alone to the east bank, and the old ceibas were bare, as the Indians had said they would be, and the pods had split. The cotton was coming down out of them over the river, slowly, in no wind at all, and settling on the brown water, and riding down it toward the sea.

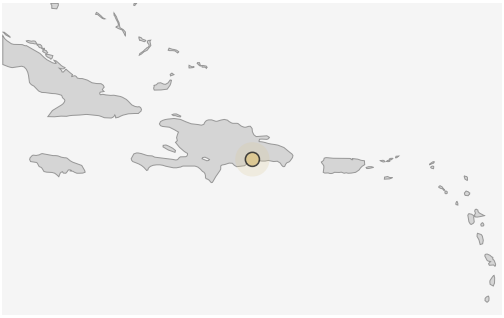
Background

The verse

> *If an intelligent man be associated for one minute only with a wise man, he will soon perceive the truth, as the tongue perceives the taste of soup.*
>
> Dhammapada 65, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the thirty young men from Pāṭheyya are among the Buddha's first followers. In the older Vinaya account they are picnicking in a grove with their wives; the one without a wife has brought a courtesan, who steals their things while they are distracted and runs. Searching for her, they meet the Buddha, who asks whether it would be better for them to seek a woman or to seek themselves. They be-

come monks on the spot, receiving bowls and robes by miracle, and take up the thirteen ascetic practices. Long afterward they return, hear him teach on the round of rebirth that has no discoverable beginning (in the Saṃyutta, the blood they have shed as slaughtered cattle, goats and pigs is more than the water of the four great oceans), and all become arahats before they rise from their seats. When the monks marvel at how quickly they understood, the Buddha tells the Tuṇḍila birth story: thirty drunken men came with nooses to buy an old woman's pig for a feast, the pig preached to them, and they took the precepts. Read the full commentary story and the birth story of the two pigs.



Santo Domingo, Hispaniola

Hispaniola, 1510–1516

The first band of Dominican friars reached Hispaniola in September 1510 under Pedro de Córdoba. They lived poorly from the start, in rough clothing and constant fasts, in a convent built of straw in Santo Domingo. On December 21, 1511, Antonio de Montesinos preached the Advent sermon that first publicly denounced the enslavement of the island's Taíno under the encomienda, the grant of Indigenous people's labor to colonists. The Taíno population of Hispaniola had fallen to about 60,000 by 1507 and was reported at about 32,000 in 1514. That year the cleric Bartolomé de las Casas, reading Ecclesiasticus 34 for a Pentecost sermon in Cuba, gave up his own encomienda.

On his second voyage, Columbus deliberately released domestic pigs in the West Indies so later expeditions would find food, and they went wild. In Spain the fattened household pig is killed in the winter matanza. In Galicia Saint Martin's day, November 11, is the traditional day for it, which gave Spanish the saying that every pig gets its Saint Martin. Cervantes has Don Quixote use it in 1615, in Ormsby's translation: "its Martinmas will come to it as it does to every pig." The ceiba, or silk-cotton tree, is native to the Caribbean. Its seed pods are full of the cottony fiber called kapok, and the commentary's Kappāsika grove is, in Pāli, a "cotton grove." The Bahoruco

mountains, where the Taíno leader Enriquillo held out against the Spanish from 1519, are in the island's southwest.

After the story of the thirty bhikkhus from Pāṭheyya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 65). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible, with the Latin Vulgate. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5·7

The Blue Cup

I know thy works, and tribulation, and poverty, (but thou art rich)
— Revelation 2:9

Saaledes har jeg hørt det, on the Zumbro.

I. The Barn Door

Wanamingo, Goodhue County, Minnesota · June 1888

Everybody in the township knew Tollef, and nobody knew his other name. The Norwegians called him Spedalske-Tollef, Leper Tollef, and the Yankees in Kenyon called him the leper, and the children called him nothing at all, because when they saw him on the road they ran.

He was fifty-eight years old and lived at the county poor farm in a room by himself at the end of the woodshed, with his own bed and his own towel and his own tin plate and cup and spoon, which nobody else touched and which were washed separately in a pan of their own. The state Board of Health had sent the rules, and the poor farm kept them. It was not cruel. They brought his dinner to the door. In winter they kept his stove going. He had come over from Sunnfjord in 1866 with the sickness already in him and his name already in the leprosy register, where the King's doctors had been writing down every leper in Norway since 1856, and he had worked as a hired man on half the farms between Kenyon and Zumbrota until his hands went. Now the fingers of his left hand were short and curled and the right was not much better, and he kept them wrapped in rags, and his face had gone thick and shiny across the brow and the nose, the way the faces of lepers go.

For twenty years nobody had known. He had been a good hired man, the best in the township at a grain cradle and later at shocking behind the binder, a quiet man who slept in the haymow and sent nothing home because there was nobody at home to send it to. He ate what was put in front of him and did not drink. Then in the harvest of 1884, at the Brekke place, he cut his hand on the knotter of the binder and did not feel it, and kept working, and Mrs. Brekke found the blood on the roller towel by the pump that night and went and looked at his hands while he slept. In the morning Brekke paid him to the day and drove him to Kenyon in the wagon without a word and set him down in front of the hardware store with his bundle. Mrs. Brekke burned the roller towel. By the end of the week it was all over the township, and by the end of the year he was at the poor farm.

He did not blame the Brekkes. He did not have the strength left over for it. He had known since he was twenty-six what was in his hands, and it had only been a matter of time.

That year the doctor from Bergen who had found the leprosy under his microscope came all the way to Red Wing to look at the Norwegians who had it. Tollef was not sent for. The county did not think him worth the train fare.

On a Sunday afternoon in June he walked six miles to Ole Kvale's barn because the woman preacher was going to speak there.

She was called Gjertrud Hovland, and she was sixty, and a widow, and she had been preaching since she was a girl in Sunnfjord, where her father had been a lay preacher of Hauge's people in the old days when the law said only the priest could speak about God to more than one family at a time, and the sheriff could take you for it. In America nobody took you for it. But the seminary men in Red Wing did not care to have a woman in the pulpit, and so she preached in barns and schoolhouses and kitchens, from Goodhue County out to the Dakota line, and the barns were full.

Ole Kvale's barn was full. They had swept the threshing floor and set planks on nail kegs, and the women sat on the planks in their black Sunday dresses with the babies, and the men stood along the walls, and the boys climbed up into the mow and hung their legs over. The big

doors were rolled open for the air. Tollef stood outside them, at the very edge, downwind, by the corner of the manure pile, where nobody would mind him and where he could just see her small black shape at the far end, standing on an upturned feed box in front of the grain bins.

She did not have a big voice. You had to be quiet to hear it. And the barn got quiet, and Tollef, outside the door with his rag hands folded in front of him, heard every word.

She read to them from the Revelation, the letter to the church in Smyrna.

> *I know thy works, and tribulation, and poverty, (but thou art rich) … Fear none of those things which thou shalt suffer: behold, the devil shall cast some of you into prison, that ye may be tried; and ye shall have tribulation ten days: be thou faithful unto death, and I will give thee a crown of life.*
>
> *— Revelation 2:9–10*

Then she talked about it for half an hour in the plain Sunnfjord way, about what it meant to be poor and what it meant to be rich, and most of the people in the barn went home and could not have told you afterward much of what she said. Tollef could not have told you either. He remembered only one part, where she stopped and looked down the length of the barn and said, *He does not tell them to cheer up. He tells them he knows. I know thy poverty. He has looked at it, all of it, and he does not look away. And then he says, thou art rich. Today, in Smyrna, in the jail, with the ten days coming. Not some other day.* A woman on the end of the nearest plank turned around then and saw Tollef in the door, and moved her baby to her other shoulder, away from him, without thinking, the way you move a baby away from a stove. Something happened to him in the middle of it, standing by the manure pile with the swallows going in and out over his head.

It was like the moment in March when the ice on the Zumbro lets go. All winter it has been one thing, white and shut and silent, and you have walked on it. Then one afternoon you hear it, a deep sound, and the

whole river moves at once, and it is water again, and you understand it was water the whole time. Tollef stood there and understood it. Whatever it was he had been waiting for since Sunnfjord, it was not coming, because it had come. It had been there the whole time. He was not going to need anything else.

He stood very still so as not to lose it, and he did not lose it.

II. The Gentleman

The section road · the same afternoon

When the meeting was over he wanted more than anything to go and tell her. But there was no getting through. Everybody wanted to shake her hand, and they were packed in the doorway three deep, and Tollef was not a man who could push into a crowd. People made room for him, but it was the wrong kind of room. So he waited by the manure pile while they sang the last hymn and while they came out blinking into the light, and while they walked her to the Liens' buggy, and while the buggy went off down the road toward the Lien place with a crowd walking behind it for the first quarter mile. Then the crowd turned back and went home to their chores, and the road was empty, and Tollef started down it after the buggy.

It was the middle of the afternoon and hot. The road ran straight along the section line between wheat on one side, still green, and corn on the other, knee-high. There were meadowlarks on the fence posts. A mile on, where the road dipped toward a creek, there was a gentleman standing in the air above the ditch.

He stood about as high as the top of a hay rack, with nothing under his boots. He wore a good black coat and a white shirt with a collar, and a gold watch chain across his vest, and he was clean in a way nobody in Goodhue County was ever clean in June, and his boots had no dust on them at all. Tollef stopped in the road and looked up at him.

Tollef, the gentleman said. He spoke a good Norwegian, the kind they speak in Christiania. *You are a poor man. You are a leper. You live in a wood-*

shed and eat off a tin plate and children run from you on the road. Nobody will sit in a pew with you. You have nothing.

Tollef did not say anything.

I can give you the Brekke place, said the gentleman. *A hundred and sixty acres, the frame house, the barn, a team of Percherons. Money in the bank in Red Wing, as much as you want. More. A doctor from Chicago, a doctor from Berlin. A hired girl to cook for you who won't mind. All you have to do is stand there in the road and say it out loud. Jesus is not the Christ. The Word is not the Word. The congregation is not the congregation. I have had enough of Jesus, and enough of the Word, and enough of the congregation. That's all. Say it once, and I'll go away, and it's all yours.*

Who are you? said Tollef.

I am the richest man you will ever meet.

Then Tollef said something nobody in the township would have believed he had in him. He told them about it later in the Liens' kitchen, exactly as it happened, and Synneve Lien wrote it down that night in the back of her almanac, and that is why we have it.

Then you are a fool, Tollef said, *and you have no shame, and you are not fit to talk to me. You stand up there and tell me I am poor. I am not poor. I am the richest man in this county. I have faith. I have kept my life as clean as a hired man can. I have a conscience, and I am afraid to do wrong. I know my catechism; I learned it for my confirmation at Førde, every word of Pontoppidan. What I had, I gave away, when I had it. And this afternoon, by Kvale's manure pile, I got a little sense. That is seven things. A man who has seven of anything is not poor. Go and find somebody poor.*

The gentleman looked at him for a moment from the air. Then he was not there anymore, and Tollef walked on down the road toward the creek.

III. The Cup

The Lien farm · late afternoon

Synneve Lien was in her kitchen baking lefse on the stove top for the preacher's supper, and the preacher was sitting at the

TABLE SHELLING PEAS INTO A BOWL, BECAUSE SHE COULD NOT stand to sit with her hands empty, when a gentleman came to the screen door.

Synneve said afterward that she never heard a wagon. He stood on the step in a black coat and a gold watch chain, with his hat in his hand, and he did not come in, and he spoke past Synneve to Gjertrud Hovland as if they knew each other. He told her all of it. What he had offered and to whom and what the leper had said back. He told it the way a man tells about a horse that would not be sold.

Gjertrud went on shelling peas.

You could stand on air over that ditch till Judgment Day, she said. *You could offer him a thousand dollars, or ten thousand, or every acre in Goodhue County with the barns on it. You will not get that man to say it. Not now.*

The gentleman put his hat on and went down the step, and Synneve went to the door to see which way he went, and there was nobody in the yard but the dog, who was lying in the shade of the pump with his chin on his paws and had not barked.

Half an hour later Tollef came up the lane.

Synneve saw him from the window and her hand went to her mouth. She had nothing in the house for him. No plate of his own, no cup. She was a good woman and she was sorry for him, but she had four children asleep upstairs and the Board of Health had sent the rules, and she stood there by the stove not knowing what to do.

Gjertrud got up and went out on the step to meet him. She brought him in. She sat him in her own chair at the table and poured coffee into her own cup, the one she had been drinking from, the blue one with the chip, and put it into his rag hands and closed his fingers around it with her fingers. Then she pulled a kitchen chair close and sat down knee to knee with him and said, *Now tell me.*

He told her. He did not have good words for it, and he said that. He told her about the river ice going out. He said that for thirty-two years, since the day in Sunnfjord when the doctor wrote his name in the book, he had been waiting for something, he did not know what, a cure or a judgment or just the end, and he had carried the waiting around with

him everywhere like a sack of seed wheat on his back, to America, to the Brekke place, to the woodshed. He said that in Kvale's barn door he had found out the sack was empty and had been empty all along, and he had set it down, and he did not think he would pick it up again. Then he told her about the gentleman in the air. She listened to all of it without saying anything, nodding a little, the way you listen to somebody tell you a thing you already know but are glad to hear.

When he was done she said, *Yes. That is it. You have it.* And she put her hand on his head, on his thin hair, the way her father used to put his hand on people's heads in Sunnfjord, and held it there a while.

He stayed until the sun was low. Before he went he told her one more thing, quietly, so Synneve at the stove would not hear, but Synneve heard. Then he thanked Synneve for the coffee, though it was not her coffee, and put on his hat and went down the lane toward the road, and Gjertrud stood on the step and watched him go.

IV. The Heifer

The Kvale lane · evening

He took the shortcut home along the lane between Kvale's pasture and the creek. The sun was going down behind him red and the whole sky was the color of the inside of a shell. There were mosquitoes coming up off the water. He was not in a hurry.

Ole Kvale had a red heifer, a yearling, with a white star on her forehead, that he had bought that spring from a man in Holden who was glad to sell her and did not say why. She had been in the pasture all day. Nobody ever found out how she got through the fence. There was a rail down afterward, at the corner by the creek, but Ole swore it had been sound in the morning.

The Kvale boy found Tollef in the lane at five the next morning when he went out to bring in the cows. He was lying on his back in the grass at the edge of the lane with his hat a little way off, and the ground around him was cut up with hoof marks, and his chest was broken in, the way a

cow will do when she goes down on her knees on a man. His face was not hurt. The boy said it looked like he was asleep in church.

The heifer was standing in the creek a little way down, up to her knees in the water, drinking.

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The old women in the township had a story about that heifer, which they told later, after it was over, and only to each other.

They said that long ago in Sunnfjord, in the old days, four farmers' sons went up to the summer pastures where a dairymaid was alone with the cows, and stayed the night with her, and in the morning they talked it over among themselves and decided to take back the silver they had given her and her own silver brooch besides, and leave no one to tell. She heard them. As they were killing her she swore she would come back for them, every one, if she had to come back as a beast to do it, and she has been coming back ever since. That is why she has a cow's shape, the old women said, the way the huldra in the old stories hides a cow's tail under her skirts. They said she had found two of the four already, one in Norway and one somewhere in the south, a long time ago. They said Tollef was the third. They said there was one more.

They did not say how they knew. Ole Kvale sold the heifer that fall to a cattle buyer from St. Paul, and nobody in the township ever saw her again.

V. The Bitter Fruit

The poor farm burying ground · three days later

THEY BURIED HIM AT THE POOR FARM, IN THE CORNER OF THE field where the county put its own, because the churches did not want a leper in their churchyards, and no pastor came. Gjertrud Hovland came. She had stayed on in the township when she heard. A good many people came with her who would not have crossed the road to Tollef while he lived, and stood around the grave in the wind with their hats in their hands, and some of them were ashamed and some were only curious.

When the box was down Gjertrud said a few words and they sang a verse of a hymn. Then nobody went home. They stood around her in the stubble and asked her things, the way people in the barn had wanted to ask.

Where is he now? said Ole Kvale, who was ashamed. *That was my heifer. Where did he go?*

He went home, said Gjertrud. *He was rich. You heard what he told the gentleman. Whatever was waiting for him, he was ready for it.*

Then why was he a leper? said somebody else, a hard old farmer from Holden who did not hold with women preachers. *If he was such a man. Why did God give him that?*

Gjertrud stood a while before she answered. The wind went over the stubble.

He told me something, she said, *on Sunday, at the end, at the door. He told me that when he was a boy of eight in Sunnfjord, in 1838, the sheriff came to take a lay preacher before the bailiff, for preaching without the priest. They led him down the road past the farms with his hands tied, and all the boys ran along beside, and Tollef ran up and spat on him. On his coat. His mother saw it and said God would remember that. Tollef said he thought about it every day of his life, and when the sickness came he knew why. He believed that. He wanted me to know it before he went.*

Nobody said anything.

I was there, said Gjertrud Hovland. *It was my father. I was nine years old and I was running along behind the sheriff's cart, and I saw a boy spit on my father's coat, and I saw my father look down at him and say, God bless you, boy. I did not know until Sunday who it was.*

Then it is true, said the farmer from Holden. *It was a judgment.*

I don't keep God's books, said Gjertrud. *I know a boy did a hard thing, and a man carried something for fifty years, and on Sunday he set it down. That's what I know.* She looked at the farmer from Holden, and at all of them, the ones who had run from Tollef on the road and the ones who had sent their children running. *And I know what Solomon says about the rest of us.*

> *Therefore shall they eat of the fruit of their own way, and be filled with their own devices. For the turning away of the simple shall slay them, and the prosperity of fools shall destroy them.*
>
> *— Proverbs 1:31–32*

Then she put on her bonnet and went back to the Liens' buggy, and the people stood around the grave a while longer in the wind, not looking at one another, and went home.

• • •

That evening the poor farm did what the Board of Health said to do. They carried Tollef's bed and his blanket and his towel out behind the woodshed and burned them, and his tin plate and his tin cup and his spoon they threw into the fire too, and scrubbed the room with lye.

At the Lien place, Synneve took the blue cup with the chip down from the shelf to break it and bury the pieces, because she had four children and she did not know what else to do. Gjertrud took it out of her hands. She washed it at the pump. Then she filled it with coffee from the pot on the back of the stove and sat down at the kitchen table and drank it, all of it, slowly, while Synneve watched, and set it down empty on the oilcloth between them.

Background

The verse

> *Fools of little understanding have themselves for their greatest enemies, for they do evil deeds which must bear bitter fruits.*
>
> Dhammapada 66, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the leper Suppabuddha sits at the outer edge of the crowd in Rājagaha, hears the Buddha teach, and is transformed. Too humble to push through the crowd, he waits until it has gone. On the road, Sakka, lord of the gods, appears in the air and tests him, promising him limitless wealth if he will renounce the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha. Suppabuddha calls him a shameless fool. He is not poor, he says, because he has the seven treasures: faith, virtue, conscience, concern, learn-

ing, giving and wisdom. Sakka reports this to the Buddha, who says that no amount of money could make the leper say it. Suppabuddha visits the Buddha, is warmly received, and on his way home is killed by a young cow. The cow is a vengeful spirit, once a courtesan murdered by four young men, who has sworn to kill all four. When the monks ask about his fate, the Buddha tells them he has been reborn among the gods, and that he was a leper because in a past life he spat on a holy man. Read the full commentary story, or about Sakka.

Goodhue County, Minnesota

Goodhue County, 1888

In the mid-nineteenth century Norway had more leprosy than any other country in Europe, most of it in poor fishing and farming communities on the west coast. In 1856 it set up the world's first national leprosy register, and isolation laws followed in 1877 and 1885. In 1873 the Bergen physician Gerhard Armauer Hansen identified the bacterium that causes the disease. Some Norwegians who had it emigrated to the Upper Midwest, and before 1890 about fifty cases were reported in Minnesota. Most patients lived with their families or on county poor farms, in rooms of their own, with their own bedding and dishes. In 1888 Hansen himself came to Minnesota and spent several weeks in Red Wing, the Goodhue County seat, studying the immigrant cases (MNopedia).

Many of those immigrants brought the revival of Hans Nielsen Hauge with them. Hauge was a lay preacher who was jailed fourteen times under the Conventicle Act, which forbade religious meetings without a parish priest until Norway repealed it in 1842. Women preached in his movement from its earliest years. In America his followers formed the Hauge Synod, a low-church body that opened its seminary in Red Wing in 1879. The old women's cow-spirit borrows from the huldra of Scandinavian folklore, a beautiful forest woman who hides a cow's tail under her skirts.

After the story of the leper Suppabuddha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 66). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.8

Snake in the Furrow

> *If thou injurest Conscience, it will have its Revenge on thee.*
> *— Poor Richard, 1739*

Sin mar a chuala mé é, on the Ridge above the Wissahickon.

I. The Long Glass

Roxborough Township, Philadelphia County · August 1739

Owen Phelan had been four years a servant and two years a free man, and he did not yet own anything that would not go in a handcart. He had come from the county of Waterford in the spring of 1733, bound for four years to pay his passage, and a Welsh farmer on the Ridge named Hugh Jones had bought the four years off the ship at the Philadelphia wharf. When they were served, Owen got what the law of the province said a servant should have at the end: two complete suits of apparel, one of them new, a new axe, a grubbing hoe and a weeding hoe. Hugh Jones died the same winter. His widow could not work the place and would not sell it, so she let Owen have the fourteen acres along the brow of the hill on the halves, and the yoke of red oxen with them, Buck and Bright, because nobody else could drive them.

In August he was breaking the stubble ground for wheat. The Welsh on the Ridge plowed a fallow three times in a summer, and this was the third. He was in the field before the sun, because by ten o'clock the heat came up out of the ground and the oxen hung their heads and would not be talked to.

From the bottom of the field he could see over the treetops into the gorge where the creek ran, and on the far shoulder of it, among the hemlocks, a roof. Every child on the Ridge knew about the Germans who had

come there in the year 'ninety-four to wait in the woods for the end of the world. They had kept a school, and doctored people, and watched the sky for a sign, and the world had not ended. Most of them were dead now or married. A few old men lived on in huts along the creek, and one of them, whom the Germans called Bruder Elias, still kept the long glass the brothers had brought from Europe. People said he climbed onto the roof every morning before sunrise and looked through it at the whole valley, every field and lane from the Schuylkill to the Germantown road, and that nothing in it was hidden from him. Farmers went down to him about strayed cattle and fevers and the right day to cut timber. Some went about thieves. He would talk to them about the cattle and the fevers and the timber, and about the thieves he would say nothing at all.

That morning, with the sun not yet over the trees, the old man came along the headland of Owen's field with the boy who lived with him, a Swiss orphan called Jost who carried his stick and his basket. Owen stopped the oxen and took off his hat. The old man nodded to him and said nothing, and Owen, who had nothing to say either, spoke to Buck and Bright and went on down the furrow.

At the corner of the field, by the stump of a chestnut where the plow had to swing wide, the old man stopped and looked at the ground.

Siehst du, Jost? Eine Schlange.

The boy came and looked. *Ich seh sie, Bruder. Eine giftige Schlange.*

Then they went on down the path into the trees toward the creek, and the old man did not look back.

Owen did not have German, but he had worked four years beside Germans, and he had the word *Schlange*, as every child on the Ridge had it. The rocks along the Wissahickon were full of rattlesnakes. He thought: I have gone up and down that corner fifty times since March and seen nothing. Then he thought of Bright, who was nervous on his near side, putting a foot down in the wrong place. He left the plow standing, took the long ox-goad with the iron prick in the end of it, and went over to kill the thing.

There was no snake. The grass by the stump was trampled flat, as if men had stood about there in the night, and in the loose earth at the end

of the last furrow lay a purse of soft brown leather with its strings pulled open. He turned it over with the goad. It was heavy. Gold showed in the mouth of it, Spanish pistoles and the broad Portugal pieces, more money than Owen had seen together in his life.

He squatted on his heels and looked at it for a long time. The old man had meant this. That much was plain. What the old man meant him to do with it was not plain at all. He thought of carrying it to Justice Pugh on the Ridge road, and of the Justice's face when an Irishman two years out of his indenture came into his kitchen with a purse of gold and a story about a hermit. He thought of the widow Jones, who would want to know where it came from. He thought of Father Greaton's little chapel in Walnut Street, where he walked once a month to hear Mass, and of what the priest would say. He did not know what to do with it, and so he did what a man will do with a thing he does not know what to do with. He put it down. He laid it back in the furrow and pushed loose earth over it with the side of his shoe, and went back to his oxen. In the evening, he thought, he would go down to the creek and ask the old man.

II. Tanbark

The same morning

In the night someone had robbed Lorenz Kunkel, the tanner at the foot of the township. The run that fed his vats went under his bark house in a stone culvert, and the thieves had come up through it on their hands and knees, knocked the stones out of his cellar wall, and carried off his strongbox with everything in it. Kunkel came down at first light to see to the fire and found his cellar open to the creek.

His sons Hannes and Peter went after them with Velten Hoffmann the constable. It was not hard. A man who has walked through a tanyard carries ground oak bark in the welts of his shoes for a mile, and the thieves had walked out through Kunkel's yard in the dark. The bark lay in crumbs up the lane, and the dew showed where they had crossed the meadow. It led them up the Ridge to the stump at the corner of the widow Jones's

fallow, where the strongbox lay on its back with the lid broken off and the grass trampled flat around it.

There the thieves' tracks went off every which way into the woods. But there was another track, fresh, that came from the plowing to the stump and back: a man in heavy shoes, one of them mended at the heel with a piece of leather that did not match. It went to a patch of earth at the end of the last furrow that had been pushed over by somebody's foot. Hannes Kunkel knelt and dug in it with his hands, and stood up with his father's purse.

Owen was at the other end of the field. He saw them standing at the stump, four men, and one of them holding up something brown, and he knew before they started toward him what they were going to say.

So, Hannes said. *You rob the house, and here you are plowing.*

They beat him in the furrow with their fists and the stock of a cart whip, while Buck and Bright stood in the yoke and swung their heads. Owen said once that he was no thief, and after that he did not say anything, because his mouth was full of blood. Velten Hoffmann let it go on a while and then pulled them off. They tied Owen's hands behind him with his own plow line and walked him down to the Ridge road to the house of Justice Pugh.

Evan Pugh was a Welshman of sixty, a justice of the peace for the county, with a stone house and a mill seat and a son at the college in New Haven. He was in his shirtsleeves with his wig off, and he did not like being taken from his breakfast. There had been three burglaries in Germantown since May. He heard Kunkel's sons and the constable, and he looked at the purse, and at the shoe with the mended heel, and at the Irishman with blood drying on his chin, and he did not want to hear anything else.

I am no thief, your worship.

Nor was the last one.

He wrote out the commitment himself. Owen Phelan, laborer, to be held in the common gaol at Third and High Streets until the next Court of Oyer and Terminer, for burglary. Burglary had been death in Pennsylvania since the year eighteen, and the Justice said so, as though

the man in front of him might not know it. *You will hang before the leaves are down,* he said, *and I shall be sorry for your mother.* Then he gave him into Velten Hoffmann's charge and told the Kunkels they might carry him to the city in their bark cart, since they were going that way.

III. The Germantown Road

Afternoon

They did not put him in the cart. They tied him by the wrists to the tail of it and he walked behind in the dust. Peter Kunkel drove, and Hannes walked alongside with the whip, and whenever the cart slowed on a hill, or Owen stumbled, or whenever it occurred to him, Hannes laid the whip across Owen's back. Velten Hoffmann walked on the other side and did not stop him. It was the hottest part of the day. The road went down through the Germantown fields to the long street of stone houses with their half-doors, and people came out onto their stoops to see the Irishman who had robbed Kunkel.

Owen walked behind the cart and said the old man's words. He did not have the German for them. He said them the way he had heard them, in the old man's deep voice and then in the boy's high one, as near as he could make it, like a man saying a prayer in a language he was never taught.

Siehst du, Jost? Eine Schlange.

Ich seh sie, Bruder. Eine giftige Schlange.

When the whip came down he said them. When it did not he said them. He said them past the Mennonite meetinghouse and past the market square, where the women stopped their bargaining and turned. He did not say another word.

At the market square Velten Hoffmann took hold of the bridle and stopped the cart.

Those are the Bruder's words, he said. *The old man on the Ridge. You say them over like a parrot. What is it?*

I'll tell it, Owen said, *if you take me back to the Justice.*

The Kunkels cursed and said it was a trick, and it was an hour back up the hill in the heat. But the constable was a Germantown man and had been down to the creek himself, about a sick child, the winter before. He turned the cart around.

Justice Pugh had his wig on now. He sat in the window of his front room with the commitment still on the table and let Owen tell it, from the time he went out to the oxen in the dark to the time the four men stood up at the stump. When it was done he did not say anything for a while. He turned his hat around in his hands.

He names Brother Elias for his witness, he said at last, not to Owen but to the room.

He had known the old man thirty years. In the year 'nine the old man had told his wife the week their first child would come, and been right. In the year 'twenty-nine he had told the Justice a thing about his own brother that the Justice had not wanted to hear, and been right about that too. Evan Pugh did not hold with nativities and figures, and conjuration was a hanging matter in the province, the same as burglary. But he had never known the old man to say a thing that was not so.

I cannot hang a man on Kunkel's word when he names that one, he said. *Nor can I let him walk off on his own. There will be a way through this. Untie his hands, Velten. We'll go down this evening.*

IV. The Sixth Month

The Wissahickon · evening

They went down the hill path at sunset, the Justice in front with his stick, Owen after him, and Velten Hoffmann behind with a lantern he did not need yet. The creek was low and loud over the rocks. The old man's hut stood above it in the hemlocks, a room of logs with a stone chimney and a ladder up to a platform on the roof, where the long glass was lashed under a piece of oilcloth. The old man was sitting on a bench by the spring. The boy was carrying water.

The Justice took off his hat. He asked his questions one at a time, the way he did at the quarter sessions, and the old man answered them the same way.

Brother Elias. Did you and the boy go this morning to a place where a man was plowing?

Yes, your worship.

What did you see there?

A purse with gold in it, by the stump of a chestnut.

When you saw it, what did you say?

The old man said it, word for word, and the boy put down his bucket and said his part, and they were the same words Owen had said behind the cart all the way to Germantown, in the same order, and Velten Hoffmann laughed out loud and then was ashamed of it.

If this man had not named you, the Justice said, *he would have hanged. He saved his neck with your words. He said them over four miles under the whip and never said anything else.*

Ja, the old man said. *I said so this morning, when I went there. A man should not do the thing he must weep for afterward.*

Inside the door of the hut, on a nail where the light from the chimney corner fell on it, hung an almanac, the thin stitched kind the printer in Market Street sold, with the moon's changes and the courts and the fairs. The brothers had always kept every almanac in the province, the old man said, to see whose sums were right about the sky. This printer's sums were not the best. But he put good things at the bottom of the months. He took it down and opened it to the sixth month, which in the province's reckoning was August, and held it out to the Justice with his thumb under a line. The boy brought a candle.

Evan Pugh read it aloud, slowly, the way he read a commitment.

> *If thou injurest Conscience, it will have its Revenge on thee.*
>
> *— Poor Richard, 1739 (August)*

He stood with the almanac in his hands for a time after that. Then he gave it back, and the old man hung it on its nail.

Owen sat on the end of the bench. His back had stiffened in the cool, and he could feel every place the whip had been. He looked down the gorge to where the Ridge farms showed through a gap in the trees, a lamp lit here and there, the fields going grey. It came to him that the old man looked at all this every morning before the sun was up, every field and lane and roof, the tanner's yard and the Justice's mill seat and the widow's fallow and the stump, and that he could see it now the way the old man must see it, all of it at once, with nothing hidden in it. His own field lay down there among the others, a small dark square, half plowed. The gold had not been his. The field was not his. The beaten back he was sitting in, which had walked four miles behind a cart saying words in a language it did not know, did not seem to him at that moment to be particularly his either. He was not frightened by this. He felt light, as if somebody had lifted a yoke off him that he had not known he was wearing.

The Justice put his hat back on. *Velten will see you home,* he said, and then, after a moment, *I'll speak to Kunkel,* which was as near as a Welsh justice of the peace came, in those days, to begging an Irishman's pardon.

• • •

The thieves were never found. Lorenz Kunkel got his gold back and rebuilt his cellar wall with an iron grate across the mouth of the culvert, and the next spring, without saying why, he sent the widow Jones a side of harness leather.

Owen finished the fallow in the second week of September and sowed it. He farmed the brow of the hill on the halves for nine more years, and then bought it. In August of the following year, breaking the stubble again, he came round to the corner by the stump in the first light and there was a rattlesnake lying in the open furrow, a big one, yellow and black, warming itself on the turned earth. He stopped the oxen. He stood with the goad in his hand and did not lift it, and the snake lay there, and after a while it moved, without any hurry, off into the chestnut sprouts. Then Owen spoke to Buck and Bright, and they leaned into the yoke, and he drew the furrow straight through the place where it had been.

Background

The verse

> *That deed is not well done of which a man must repent, and the reward of which he receives crying and with a tearful face.*
>
> Dhammapada 67, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, thieves who have robbed a rich man of Sāvatthī divide their loot in a farmer's field, and one of them drops a purse of a thousand coins. At dawn the Buddha passes the field with Ānanda and says, "See, Ānanda, a poisonous snake," and Ānanda answers, "I see it, a deadly poisonous snake." The farmer goes with his goad to kill it, finds the purse, covers it with earth and goes on plowing. The owners track the thieves to the field, find the purse, beat the farmer and bring him before the king, who orders him put to death. Led away under the whip, he repeats the two sentences and nothing else, and when he is allowed to explain, the king takes him to the Buddha that evening to confirm the story. The Buddha says a wise man should not do a deed he must afterward repent, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda, the attendant who answers.

Roxborough Township and the Wissahickon, Pennsylvania

The Ridge and the almanac, 1739

In 1694 the German mystic Johannes Kelpius and some forty followers settled along Wissahickon Creek northwest of Philadelphia, believing the end of the world would come that year. When it did not, they kept a school, shared their medical knowledge and went on searching the stars. Kelpius died in 1708 and the community dwindled, though some who had joined it, among them Conrad Matthai and Christopher Witt, stayed on in the neighborhood. Bruder Elias is invented. Philadelphia County was full of Irish and German servants who had sold years of labor for their passage; Pennsylvania's 1700 law gave a servant at the end of his term two suits of clothes, one new, an axe, a grubbing hoe and a weeding hoe. The Jesuit Joseph Greaton

opened St. Joseph's in Philadelphia in 1733, the one place in the English-speaking world where Mass could then be said openly. Under the province's criminal act of 1718, burglary, like conjuration and witchcraft, was punishable by death, and men awaiting the Court of Oyer and Terminer were held in the stone prison at Third and High Streets.

Benjamin Franklin began printing Poor Richard's Almanack for the year 1733 under the name of Richard Saunders, a poor stargazer, and by 1739 was printing and selling it on Market Street. Besides the calendar, the weather and the stars, each month carried proverbs and squibs, most of them borrowed from books like Thomas Fuller's *Gnomologia* and sharpened in the rewording; the almanac for 1739 began its year in March, as the province's calendar still did, so its sixth month was August, and that is where "If thou injurest Conscience" stands. Almanac makers were often pestered to find thieves and stray horses by the stars; Poor Richard complained of it in his preface for 1742.

After the story of a farmer from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 67). The original. The verse from Benjamin Franklin's *Poor Richard* for 1739. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.9

The Roof Walk

> *But oh! shipmates! on the starboard hand of every woe, there is a sure delight; and higher the top of that delight, than the bottom of the woe is deep.*
> *— Moby-Dick, ch. 9*

The way it was spun to me, on the wharves below Johnny Cake Hill.

I. Eight Bunches

County Street, New Bedford · June 1857

Joseph Sumner grew flowers on a lot at the top of the town that belonged to Captain Barzillai Hathaway, and every morning of the summer, before the Captain's household was up, he cut eight bunches and carried them in a flat basket on his head to the kitchen door of the Captain's house on County Street. Roses, mostly, the red ones the town was proud of, and a few white, with honeysuckle and mignonette for the smell. The cook gave him a dollar on Saturdays. He lived in a two-room cottage on the same lot with his wife Ann and their two boys, and the Captain owned the cottage too, and the well, and very nearly the ground the boys walked on to school.

The Captain was called the Commodore along the wharves, though he had never commanded anything but whaleships, because he walked down to his counting room every morning as if he were taking a squadron out. He had made three voyages as master and come home rich from the third, and he had shares now in eleven ships. Men who had sailed under him said he once kept a boatsteerer in irons in the run for fifty days off the coast of Japan, for answering back. Men who owed him money crossed the street. He had buried his wife and a son, the son lost at sea,

and there was a cenotaph to the son in the Bethel on Johnny Cake Hill, a marble tablet with a broken mast cut in it, and the roses were for the dining room, where the Commodore ate alone.

On the morning this happened Joseph was coming down County Street at half past five with the basket on his head when he met Uncle Simeon Coombs coming up.

Everybody in New Bedford knew Uncle Simeon. He was a Gay Head man, from the cliffs at the west end of Martha's Vineyard, and he had gone whaling at fourteen and been a boatsteerer for thirty years, and come ashore at last with one hand stiff from a line that ran out through it off the Line Islands. He and his wife had kept a boardinghouse for colored seamen below Water Street, and since she died he kept it alone. He was past seventy. He met every ship that came in, whatever the hour, and took the men who had nowhere to go up to his house and fed them, and when the agents' runners came round to sign green boys for the next voyage he stood in his doorway and read the articles aloud so the boys would know what they were signing. Sailors of every color and nation knew his name in every port from Talcahuano to the Bay of Islands. He walked up through the town every morning to sit with whoever was sick in it. He did not say much. His great-niece Lyddy, who was twelve, walked behind him and carried a covered basket.

That morning, people said afterward, there was a light on him. The ones who saw him at the bottom of the street said the sun must have been coming off the harbor behind him. The ones who saw him at the top, where the sun was not up yet, could not account for it. It was the color of the water at noon in the Pacific, a whaleman said, the color it goes when you look down into it from the masthead and can see a hundred feet. It did not hurt to look at. It came off his old black coat and his white hair and his hands.

Joseph Sumner stopped in the road with the basket on his head and looked at him, and something in him wanted very badly to give him something, and he had nothing to give him but the Commodore's roses.

He stood there and thought it through, because he was a careful man. They are not mine, he thought. They are the Commodore's, or as good as.

If they do not come to the kitchen door this morning he will turn me off the lot and out of the cottage, and nobody on County Street will buy a flower from a man the Commodore has turned off. Ann and the boys will be in the road. Then he thought: The most the Commodore can give me is a dollar on Saturday, as long as I last. And the most he can take from me is the same. He took the basket down off his head.

Joseph threw two handfuls of roses toward the old man, the way you would throw rice at a wedding, and they did not come down. They went up over his head and stopped there and hung, like an awning over a shop door. He threw two more, and they went round to his right side and hung there in the air, from his shoulder down to his boots, like a curtain. Two more went behind him and stayed. The last two went to his left. The stems were all turned in toward him and the flowers all turned out, red and white, and in front of him there was a space left open, as though for a door.

Uncle Simeon looked at him for a long moment, and nodded, and went on up the street. The roses went with him. When he walked they walked. When he stopped at the corner of Union Street to let a dray go by, they stopped and hung still around him, and not a petal fell.

II. Union Street

The same morning

A GIRL SHAKING A RUG OUT OF A WINDOW ON COUNTY STREET saw it first and screamed, and then the street was full. Nobody ran away. People came out of the houses half dressed, the Irish girls from the kitchens and the masters of the houses in their dressing gowns, and they went up to him and walked all the way around him, slowly, the roses and all, as if it were the only proper thing to do, and some went round him three times, and then fell in behind. By the time he reached the top of the town there were a hundred people following him, and by the time he came back down Union Street toward the water there were a thousand. Whalemen came off the ships in the harbor in their boats. Coopers came out of the shops with their adzes in their hands. Quaker women in grey

BONNETS WALKED BESIDE CAPE VERDEAN SAILORS WITH GOLD rings in their ears, and a Gay Head boatsteerer carried a white child on his shoulders so she could see. A brass band that had been practicing for the Fourth of July came out of its hall in its shirtsleeves and fell in ahead with the brass and the big drum and played whatever they knew, and people sang whatever they knew, and everybody waved whatever they had, handkerchiefs, hats, a Portuguese flag, a pair of drawers off somebody's line.

Uncle Simeon walked through it all as if it were an ordinary morning and went where he went every morning. He sat an hour with a boatsteerer from Barbados who had come home from the Arctic with his feet frozen, while the crowd waited in the lane and the roses hung around his chair. He went to a widow on Middle Street whose husband's ship had been posted missing. He went to the jail, where a green hand who had deserted at Fayal was being held for the agent. All day he walked, three miles or more up and down the town, and the drum went before him, and the roses never fell.

Joseph Sumner walked behind him a little way, as far as the head of Union Street. He was so happy he did not know what to do with his hands. He looked into the light that came off him, through the open place where the roses made a door, and he felt as if he had dived off a ship's rail into warm red water a long way down. Then he went home to his cottage with the empty basket on his arm.

III. The Commodore's Yard

Forenoon

ANN WAS AT THE WASHTUB. SHE LOOKED AT THE BASKET.

Where are the flowers?

I gave them to Uncle Simeon.

The Commodore's flowers.

He can turn us off the lot, Joseph said. *I know that. I thought about it in the road. I would do it again. Listen. You can hear them from here.*

She could hear the drum down in the town and the shouting. She did not believe a word of the rest of it. Ann Sumner had been born free in Providence and had seen what happened to people who crossed men like the Commodore. She had seen a whole family put out of a house near the docks with their bedsteads in the snow, and she had seen what became of a man the merchants agreed not to hire. She told Joseph so. She told him she had the boys to think of, if he had not. Then she dried her hands, put on her good bonnet, took a boy by each hand, and walked up County Street to the Commodore's front door, which she had never in her life gone near, and asked for the Captain.

He came out into the hall himself. He was a big grey man with a face like a shut door.

Captain Hathaway, my husband gave your roses away this morning to Uncle Simeon Coombs, every one of them, and came home with the basket empty. I told him what I thought. I have come to tell you that whatever he has done, good or bad, it is his doing and not mine. I have left him. That is all I came to say.

The Commodore had seen Uncle Simeon go by his window an hour before in his pavilion of roses, with the band in front. He had stood at the window with his coffee going cold and his hand flat on the glass. He looked at the woman in the hall and the two little boys staring at the iron harpoons worked into his front fence, and he understood her perfectly. He made his face as hard as it had ever been on a quarterdeck.

He gave my flowers to somebody else?

Yes, sir.

Then you did right to leave him. Go home, madam. I will know how to deal with Joseph Sumner.

When she had gone he took his hat and went out by the side door, and down through the town by back lanes, faster than anyone had seen him go since he came ashore, until he found the crowd in Middle Street. It opened for him because it always had. He went in through the door the roses made and took off his hat to Uncle Simeon, and what he said to him nobody heard. Nobody in New Bedford knew that on the night the news came of his son's ship, nine years before, the Commodore had

walked down below Water Street in the dark and knocked at the boardinghouse door, and that the old harpooneer had sat with him in his kitchen until morning without saying anything at all. He walked beside him after that, the two of them alone inside the flowers, and the crowd behind.

At noon Uncle Simeon came to the Commodore's gate on County Street. The Commodore held it open and asked him to come into the house. Uncle Simeon shook his head. He went to the bench under the horse-chestnut tree in the front yard, where the street could see him over the fence, and sat down there, and the roses settled around the bench and hung. Lyddy sat on the grass at his feet.

The Commodore understood that too, after a minute. If the old man went inside, the people in the street would see a closed door. Out here they could see what Joseph Sumner had done. He called the cook and the girls and had every chair in the house carried out to the yard, and the dining table, and the cold dinner that had been meant for him alone, and then the bread in the house and the cheese and the ham and the pies, and when that was gone he sent to the baker's. He served Uncle Simeon himself, on his wife's Canton plates, and he stood behind his chair while he ate, the way a steward stands behind a captain. The street ate in his yard until the middle of the afternoon. Then Uncle Simeon thanked him, and got up, and went down the hill toward the water with the roses around him and the band and the people behind, and the Commodore walked with him as far as the corner and came back.

IV. The Roof Walk

Evening

He sent for Joseph Sumner at five o'clock. Joseph came to the kitchen door, as he had come every morning for six summers, and the cook sent him round to the front.

When you threw my roses at him, the Commodore said, *what did you say?*

I said to myself, sir, let the Commodore turn me off the lot. I said the most he can give me is a dollar on Saturday, and the most he can take is the same.

The Commodore looked at him for a long time.

You are a bigger man than I am, he said.

Then he gave him eight of everything he could think of. He gave him the deed to the lot and the cottage, made out that evening by a lawyer who was fetched from his supper. He gave him eight hundred dollars. He gave him eight cords of seasoned oak and eight barrels of sperm oil, enough to light the cottage the rest of his life, and eight shares in the bark that was fitting out at his wharf, and a standing order for eight bunches every summer morning at twice the price, as long as either of them lived. Ann came back from wherever she had gone to wait and found her husband sitting on the step of a house that belonged to him, with a piece of paper in his hands, laughing.

• • •

Walking home down Union Street in the long June evening, with the crowd thinning out behind them at last, Lyddy asked her great-uncle what Joseph Sumner was going to get for it.

You saw what he got. The Commodore gave him the house.

I mean after. In the end.

Uncle Simeon did not answer right away.

Don't you think it was a little thing he did, he said. *He gave the whole of what he had, and he thought it would cost him the roof over his children, and he gave it anyway and was glad. A man who has done that once is not going all the way down again. Not ever. And one of these days he will find the whole of it by himself, the way some men find a passage nobody ever charted, with nobody to show him and nobody behind.*

His house below Water Street had a roof walk on top, a little railed platform between the chimneys, where he had watched for ships when he was ashore and his wife had watched for his when he was not. When he came to his own door and went in, the roses that had hung around him all day did not come in after him. They went up past the eaves, slowly, all together, and came down on the roof walk, and lay there along the rail in a heap, red and white, as if somebody had come home from sea and thrown them up.

That night the boarders at his long table could talk about nothing else. There were eleven of them, from Nantucket and Fayal and Barbados and Bonny and the Sandwich Islands, and two Gay Head men, and they went over it and over it. A gardener had given away his master's roses and got a house for it the same day, and money, and oil, and shares in a ship. It was the luckiest throw anybody had ever heard of. One of them had been to the Bethel that afternoon to see the son's tablet, and complained that the pulpit there was only a plain box and not built like a ship's bow, the way it was in the book.

Uncle Simeon came out of the kitchen with the coffeepot and asked them what they were talking about. They told him.

It was not the house he was glad about, he said. *He was glad on Union Street, with nothing in his basket. Lyddy, get the book.*

The book was a whaling story a boatsteerer had left in his front room six years before, with his name in it and a smell of the forecastle still on the pages. Nobody else in New Bedford seemed to have read it, but his boarders always did, because it began in their own town and in their own chapel, and had a Gay Head harpooneer in it, which Uncle Simeon said was the best thing about it. Lyddy brought it, and Uncle Simeon found the place without looking for it, near the end of the sermon, and gave it back to the girl to read, because his own eyes were tired. Lyddy read it out over the coffee, in the lamplight, with the roses outside on the roof.

> *Delight is to him—a far, far upward, and inward delight—who against the proud gods and commodores of this earth, ever stands forth his own inexorable self.*
>
> *And eternal delight and deliciousness will be his, who coming to lay him down, can say with his final breath—O Father!—chiefly known to me by Thy rod—mortal or immortal, here I die. I have striven to be Thine, more than to be this world's, or mine own.*
>
> *— Moby-Dick, ch. 9*

The Gay Head men laughed at *commodores*, and then nobody laughed.

In the morning Joseph Sumner cut eight bunches of roses before it was light, the way he always had, and put them in the flat basket and carried it on his head down County Street to the Commodore's kitchen door. The dew was still on them. On the roof walk below Water Street the others lay where they had come down, and stayed fresh, Lyddy said, all that week, and the gulls would not stand on the rail.

Background

The verse

> *No, that deed is well done of which a man does not repent, and the reward of which he receives gladly and cheerfully.*
>
> Dhammapada 68, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the garland-maker Sumana brings King Bimbisāra eight measures of jasmine every morning. One day he meets the Buddha entering Rājagaha in a blaze of light and, reckoning that the king can at worst kill or banish him, throws all eight handfuls over the Teacher instead. The flowers hang in the air on four sides like a pavilion and travel with him, and the whole city follows to the sound of drums, waving cloths. Sumana's wife, terrified, takes the children to the king and disowns her husband. The king, a secret disciple, feigns anger and sends her home, then joins the Buddha, who chooses to sit in the palace courtyard rather than indoors so that everyone can see what the garland-maker has done. Afterward the king gives Sumana eight of everything. Asked by Ānanda what the man's reward will be, the Buddha says he will not fall into a state of suffering for a hundred thousand aeons and will one day become a solitary Buddha; the flowers fall onto the roof of the Buddha's chamber, and that evening he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Bimbisāra, the king.

New Bedford, Massachusetts

New Bedford, 1857

By 1857 the harbor of New Bedford held 329 vessels worth more than twelve million dollars, and the town counted as the richest per head in North America. Its whaling fortunes built the mansions and gardens along County Street; its crews were drawn from everywhere: free and escaped African Americans, Wampanoag men from Gay Head on Martha's Vineyard and Pequots, Cape Verdeans, Pacific Islanders and Europeans. The town was an important stop on the Underground Railroad; by 1853 it had 1,008 African American residents, some 700 of them escaped from slavery, and Frederick Douglass had worked on its wharves for three years after his own escape. The Port Society dedicated the Seamen's Bethel on Johnny Cake Hill in 1832; its walls carry cenotaphs for whalemen lost at sea. Today the old waterfront is the New Bedford Whaling National Historical Park.

Herman Melville sat in the Bethel before he shipped out on the whaler *Acushnet* in January 1841, and ten years later opened Moby-Dick in New Bedford, with Father Mapple's sermon on Jonah preached from a pulpit shaped like a ship's bow. The book sold poorly and was out of print by the end of Melville's life. The real pulpit in 1841 was most likely a plain box; the prow now standing in the Bethel was inspired by the 1956 film of the novel and first put up in 1961. Uncle Simeon, the Sumners and Captain Hathaway are invented; Melville's own harpooneer Tashtego is a Gay Head man.

After the story of Sumana the garland-maker from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 68). The original. The verse from Father Mapple's sermon in Herman Melville's *Moby-Dick* (1851). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.10

Honey on the Knife

> *They are like a child who tries to eat a little honey smeared on the edge of a knife.*
> *— Sutra of Forty-two Sections 22*

Iwa gachi naneun deureotda, on Little River Turnpike.

I. Shirts

Annandale, Virginia · spring 1995

Han Myeong-su had a dry cleaner in a strip of shops on Little River Turnpike, between a Korean bakery and a store that sold rice cookers and phone cards. He had come over in 1979 and pressed other men's shirts for six years before he could buy a counter of his own, and he still pressed every collar himself, because a collar was where people looked. His wife had died the winter their daughter turned twelve. After that it was the two of them and the machines.

Seo-yeon worked the counter after school, and then after college, when she had a degree in accounting from George Mason and no particular wish to use it. She was quiet at the register. She had a way of looking at a stain as if it had told her something, and a coolness about her that the aunts at the bakery next door said was like water in a stone basin. Customers came back.

Men came back. A deacon's son from a Presbyterian church in Centreville brought one shirt at a time, so he would have a reason to come back on Thursday. A lawyer from Tysons brought shirts that were already clean. A Marine lieutenant from Quantico brought his dress blues in March and asked whether she ever went into the city. A man who owned three beauty-supply stores in Northeast Washington brought his mother,

who looked at Seo-yeon's hands while Seo-yeon wrote the ticket. Their mothers called the house in the evening. Mr. Han did not know what to say to them, so he said she was young.

Kwon Jang-ho did not bring shirts. He was her mother's cousin's son, two years older, and he fixed the machines. He had grown up in the back of the shop with her, doing homework on the floor under the conveyor while the bagged suits went around over their heads. When they were small the aunts used to say those two would marry, and laugh. He was the only one who had never heard it as a joke. At twenty-five he could take apart a solvent machine in an afternoon and put it back so it ran quieter than new, and he came by the shop more than the machines needed.

One night in April, after the gate was down, Mr. Han sat on the bench by the press with his hands on his knees.

I can't give you to all of them, he said. *Every one I say no to, his mother takes her coats somewhere else.* He was quiet for a while. *Your mother used to say you would have been happy at the temple. I never let her say it in front of you.*

He meant the temple in Centreville, where he went on the first and fifteenth of the lunar month and stood at the back. He meant, could she leave home. Shave her head. Become a sunim.

When she was five her grandmother had taken her to the public bath in Seoul, sat her on a low stool, and poured the first bowl of hot water over her head. She had never forgotten it: the heat going down over her ears and shoulders all at once, and every tight thing in her coming loose. Her father's question felt like that.

Yes, she said. *Appa. Yes.*

II. The Candles

Centreville · winter 1996

The temple was a brick ranch house and a converted horse barn on four acres off Braddock Road, with a gravel lot and a stone lantern somebody had driven down from New Jersey in the back of a van. The Dharma hall was the barn. In the winter it held the cold like a well.

As a postulant she did what she was told. She washed rice and scrubbed pots and cut radishes, and she was given the hall to keep. In her week she rose at half past two, swept the floor from the altar to the door, filled the water bowl, and lit the two candles before the abbot came across the yard at three with the wooden moktak to wake the house.

On the fourth morning of her second week she lit the candles and did not get up.

Nothing had happened. The flame stood on its wick in the cold room the way a person stands who has nowhere else to be. It leaned when the furnace came on and straightened when it stopped. She looked at it, and went on looking, and at some point the one who was looking set itself down the way you set down a bag you have carried so long you forgot it was in your hand. She did not pick it up again. When the abbot came in with the moktak she was still kneeling there, and he looked at her face, and struck the moktak, and the morning went on.

At breakfast the cook put the scorched rice from the bottom of the pot into her bowl.

The cook was a small woman of nearly seventy in a quilted gray vest, with a scarf over her hair and forearms like a baker's. She had been widowed at twenty-two in the first summer of the war, and had cooked for thirty years at a nuns' monastery in the south of Korea before her son brought her to Virginia. Everyone called her Bosal-nim, which is what you call a laywoman at a temple, and which also means bodhisattva, though nobody thought about that. She spoke very little. She gave the scorched rice to no one. That morning she scraped it out of the pot in one brown sheet and put it in the postulant's bowl and went back to the stove.

Seo-yeon went to Korea that spring. She studied four years at a seminary for nuns in the mountains and took the full precepts, three hundred and forty-eight of them, and came back to Centreville in 2002 in gray robes with the Dharma name Cheongryeon. Blue Lotus. The aunts at the bakery said it suited her. She had the same coolness. People who had known her at the counter found it hard to look straight at her and hard to look away.

III. The Hermitage

Page County, Virginia · 2008

A dentist's widow in McLean left the temple a cabin and twelve acres in the Page Valley, south of Luray, between the long wall of Massanutten and the Blue Ridge. You reached it by a gravel lane that ran through Delmer Breeden's pasture. Halfway along, the lane bent around a round hollow in the grass with a sycamore growing out of the bottom of it. After rain the hollow held water. The cows went around it.

That's a sink, Delmer told her the first week. He was a tall man in his sixties who kept beef cattle and drove a school bus. *Whole valley's hollow underneath. Luray Caverns is just the part they charge you to see.*

In Korea old nuns lived alone in hermitages up the mountain, and Cheongryeon asked to live at the cabin alone. The abbot did not like it. The board did not like it. She asked a second time, and then they said yes, because she was the kind of person who did not ask a third time, and because it was a long drive and nobody else wanted to go.

She sat in the front room in the morning and the evening. She grew lettuce and perilla and long green peppers in a plot behind the cabin, and fed a cat that was not hers. There was no bath in the cabin, only a kitchen sink, so a previous owner had built a shed out back with a shower and a propane water heater. On the first and fifteenth she went down to Centreville in whatever car the temple sent.

Jang-ho brought her groceries. Somebody had to, and he drove all over the state anyway, fixing machines for the Korean cleaners from Frederick to Fredericksburg; by one newspaper's count four out of five cleaners around Washington were Korean, and he knew the back room of every one. Once a month his white van came up Delmer's lane with rice and tofu and kimchi from the H Mart and a box of whatever his mother had made. He was divorced by then. He fixed the pump. He fixed the pilot on the water heater, and kept the key to the shed. He sat on the cabin step and drank the tea she made and looked at her.

Aren't you lonely out here?

No.

I would be.

I know, she said.

In May she went down to Centreville for ten days before the Buddha's Birthday to fold paper petals with the bosals, thousands of them, pink and white and green, glued around wire frames into lotus lanterns to hang over the parking lot. While she was gone Jang-ho drove up the lane with the key on his ring. He was good with small wires. He put a camera in the light fixture of the shed.

In June he came back with groceries and said he wanted to look at the heater. He was out there a while.

In August he sat on the step and asked her to leave the robes. He had money put away. He would take her anywhere she wanted, California, Seoul, anywhere. He had loved her since they were eight years old under the conveyor, and she knew it, and she had gone and done this.

Jang-ho, she said. *Go home.*

He stood up. *You'll be sorry,* he said.

She was already looking at the lettuce.

IV. The Link

Centreville · October 2008

That fall the banks were failing on the television, and men who had been laid off stopped buying suits, and the cleaners on Little River Turnpike stood around their counters at three in the afternoon with nothing to press. On a Tuesday in October a link went around.

It came first in emails, with a subject line in Korean that said you should see what the temple's nun is. Then it was on a community message board where people sold used Hondas and asked for immigration lawyers. Somebody had it taken down. Somebody put it back up. It was of her, in the shed, and it is not going to be described here. Enough people did that.

The cook knew before anyone told her, because of the silence when she came into the temple kitchen on Wednesday and five bosals stopped talking at once.

The abbot drove to Page County himself. Cheongryeon was on her knees in the pepper plants. He stood at the end of the row and told her, badly, the way men tell such things, and she listened with dirt on her hands. When he was done she got up and asked him where it would have been. Then she walked out to the shed and stood in the doorway and looked up.

The deputy who came from Luray was a young man with a crew cut who took off his hat in the cabin and did not know where to look. He stood on a kitchen chair and took the camera out of the fixture and put it in a paper bag. Unlawful creation of an image of another, he said. In Virginia that was a Class 1 misdemeanor. Up to a year.

And putting it on the internet, the abbot said.

The deputy turned his hat over in his hands. *Sir, I'm not sure there's a law for that part. Not yet.*

Cheongryeon signed the statement with both her names. The deputy asked whether she was all right, and whether there was somewhere else she could stay.

I live here, she said.

On Sunday she came down to Centreville and walked into the Dharma hall and sat in her place on the left, where she had always sat, and did the bows. People looked at the floor. A few looked at her. After the service the board met downstairs in the fellowship room, at folding tables, with barley tea in paper cups. Mr. Yoon Sang-cheol presided. He owned fourteen cleaners between Chantilly and Springfield, and he had paid for the new roof on the barn.

A man who sold insurance said that for the good of the temple, and for her own good, she should perhaps return to lay life for a while, until people forgot. The Korean papers in Annandale had not printed anything yet. They would.

A woman from the flower committee asked the abbot straight out whether a sunim could still be a sunim after this. After so many people. Whether she was still clean.

Someone else asked what she had been doing out there by herself in the first place. What she had expected.

The abbot said he would write to the order in Seoul.

They asked Cheongryeon if she wanted to say anything. She had been sitting at the end of a table with her hands folded in her sleeves.

I'm living the way I lived before, she said. *If the temple wants the robes back, it can have them. I'll fold them.*

The cook was upstairs in the kitchen the whole time, washing the rice for Monday.

V. The Sink

Page County · November 2008

Nobody knows why Jang-ho drove out to the Page Valley one night in the middle of November. To take the light fixture down himself, maybe. To say he was sorry, or to say something worse. It was raining hard, the first real rain in weeks. Cheongryeon was asleep and heard nothing. Delmer Breeden, in the farmhouse at the head of the lane, heard nothing either.

In the morning Delmer's cows were bawling at the fence. He walked out in his boots. Where the sink had been there was a hole in the pasture thirty feet across, with the sycamore lying over it like a dropped match, and the white van standing on its nose in brown water at the bottom. Jang-ho was inside. The rescue squad came out from Luray, and it took them until afternoon to bring him up.

Delmer said he had driven that lane at dusk with a round bale on the front of the tractor, and it was solid. He said it to the deputy and to the man from the paper and to everybody at the feed store, and he was not a man who told stories. The ground had opened under that van, he said, like a mouth.

On Little River Turnpike they said the same thing, with less doubt. The earth had swallowed him. The old women at the bakery said there was an old word for it, for the way the earth takes certain men, and that it had taken men before, in the Buddha's time and since. They said it the way you would say a man was hit by a train. Nobody said it was a judgment. Nobody had to.

Cheongryeon went to the funeral home in Annandale and chanted for him for an hour beside the closed casket while his mother sat in the front row and would not turn her head. Then she went back to the valley in the temple's car.

The next Sunday Mr. Yoon came into the temple kitchen with the abbot behind him. The cook was rolling kimbap on a bamboo mat for the lunch after service, sixty rolls, her knife laid crosswise on the board with a little sesame oil on the blade so the rice wouldn't stick.

He thought he'd get away with it, Mr. Yoon said. He sounded almost sorry for him.

The cook finished the roll and set it with the others. She picked up the knife and looked at the oil on the edge of it. Then she said something from the old sutra the nuns used to read in the evenings at the monastery where she cooked, the one they say was the first ever carried into China. She said it in Korean. When it went into the temple bulletin the next month, somebody found the English for it in a book printed in Chicago in 1906.

> *People cleave to their worldly possessions and selfish passions so blindly as to sacrifice their own lives for them. They are like a child who tries to eat a little honey smeared on the edge of a knife. The amount is by no means sufficient to appease his appetite, but he runs the risk of wounding his tongue.*
>
> *— Sutra of Forty-two Sections 22*

It tastes sweet, the cook said. *For a while. Until it's ripe.* She wiped the blade with a cloth and began to cut. *Then it isn't sweet.*

VI. The Leaf

Centreville · December 2008

The letter from Seoul did not come. The question did not go away. It was in the way the flower committee arranged its chrysanthemums with their backs to the left side of the hall, and in the way men

WHO HAD BROUGHT SHIRTS TO THE COUNTER ON LITTLE RIVER Turnpike thirteen years before now stopped talking when her name came up. At the December board meeting the woman from the flower committee asked it again. This time she did not ask the abbot. She turned around in her folding chair toward the kitchen pass-through, where the cook was wiping the counter.

Bosal-nim. You cooked for nuns thirty years. You tell us. Is she still clean?

The cook came out of the kitchen with the rag in her hand. She was eighty and walked as if her feet hurt, which they did. She stood at the end of the tables for a while before she said anything.

Has anyone here been to the lotus ponds in Washington? By the river. Kenilworth.

A few of them had. You took the children in July, when the lotuses were up.

Go after it rains, the cook said. *Look at a leaf. The rain sits on it like quicksilver. Big drops. The wind comes and tips the leaf, and the water runs off, all of it, and the leaf is dry. You can touch it. Dry.* She folded the rag. *The water was on it. Where's the water now? Is the leaf wet?*

Nobody answered. The furnace came on.

What happened to her happened, the cook said. *It didn't stick. It doesn't stick to somebody like that. It's still sticking to all of you.*

Then she turned to Mr. Yoon, who was looking at his hands.

And buy a house. In town, near people, near a bus. No sunim lives out in a field by herself again. Not because of her. Because of men.

Mr. Yoon bought an end-unit townhouse off Route 29 in January, with a parking space and a little square of yard and a bus stop at the corner, a mile and a half from the temple. The board wrote it into the minutes: a nun practicing alone would live there and not in the county. The cabin in the Page Valley was kept for retreats, and no one went to it alone. Delmer Breeden filled the sink in the pasture with forty tons of shot rock and graded the lane around it the long way.

• • •

Cheongryeon moved in the first week of January with two boxes and a cushion. The cook came with her in Mr. Yoon's car and walked through the four small rooms as if she were checking a kitchen, and opened the refrigerator, and shut it, and put a foil packet on the counter before she left.

The next morning Cheongryeon got up at half past two and swept the front room and lit a candle in the window. A man across the lot was scraping frost off his windshield for the early shift at Dulles, and he looked up at the light and then went back to scraping. When she had sat, she went into the kitchen and opened the foil. It was the scorched rice from the bottom of the pot, in one brown sheet. She broke a piece into a bowl and poured hot water over it from the kettle, and watched the rice loosen and turn the water the color of weak tea, the way it did in every kitchen in Korea, and drank it.

Background

The verse

> *As long as the evil deed done does not bear fruit, the fool thinks it is like honey; but when it ripens, then the fool suffers grief.*
>
> Dhammapada 69, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Uppalavaṇṇā, "the one with the color of the blue lotus," is a treasurer's daughter of Sāvatthī sought by so many kings and rich men that her father, unable to answer them all, asks whether she would leave the world. She agrees as gladly as if her head had been anointed with oil. As a new nun, taking her turn to light the lamp and sweep the Uposatha hall, she makes the flame her object of meditation and reaches awakening. Later she lives alone in a forest hut. A young man, her cousin, who has desired her since before she went forth, hides in the hut and assaults her; as he leaves, the earth opens and swallows him. The Buddha speaks this verse about the fool for whom evil tastes like honey until it ripens. When others wonder whether one who is awakened still feels desire, he answers that desire does not cling to such a person, as water does not cling to a lotus leaf, and he asks King Pasenadi to build a dwelling for nuns inside the city, so that they no longer live alone in the forest. **At the editor's direction, this retelling changes one thing: there is no sexual assault. In its place is a different violation of her body and her solitude.**

Her cousin hides a camera where she bathes and spreads the images. Everything else follows the source in order. Read the full commentary story, or about Uppalavaṇṇā.

Centreville and the Page Valley, Virginia

Northern Virginia and the Page Valley, 2008

Korean immigrants began building businesses in Annandale, along Little River Turnpike, in the 1990s, and the area is now often called Koreatown; Fairfax County has nearly 40,000 Korean residents. Dry cleaning was a Korean trade across the region: in 2001 the Washington Post counted about 80 percent of the area's 1,200 cleaners as Korean-owned (Capital News Service). Korea is one of the few countries where the full ordination of women survived; nuns of the Jogye Order keep some 348 precepts (Korea Times). The Sutra of Forty-two Sections is traditionally held to be the first Buddhist sutra translated into Chinese; the English here is D. T. Suzuki's, from Soyen Shaku's *Sermons of a Buddhist Abbot* (Chicago: Open Court, 1906). The temple, the cabin and all the people are fictional.

Most of Virginia's karst follows Interstate 81 through the Valley and Ridge, where acidic water dissolves limestone into caves and the ground above can drop without warning, usually slowly and sometimes all at once; the state's highway department has recorded about 500 sinkholes that damaged roads in thirty years (Virginia Energy). Luray Caverns, found in 1878, lies under the Page Valley. Secretly filming a person undressed where she expects privacy had been a Class 1 misdemeanor in Virginia since 1994 (§ 18.2-386.1), but spreading such images was not a crime in the state until 2014 (§ 18.2-386.2). The lotus ponds the cook remembers are at Kenilworth Park & Aquatic Gardens in northeast Washington, where the lotuses bloom in the hot months of summer.

After the story of Uppalavaṇṇā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 69). The original. Scripture from the Sutra of Forty-two Sections, tr. D. T. Suzuki, in Soyen Shaku, *Sermons of a Buddhist Abbot* (1906). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.11

The Sedge Straw

It is the result of the disease, not the cause.
— Soil Pollution, Question 41

This is how the old singers told it, on the brow of Sand Mountain.

I. The Visiting Preacher

Sand Mountain, Alabama · the fall of 1856

There was a man named Eli Tidmore who had a good farm on the brow and no preacher nearer than the valley, so he built a room onto his house and kept one. The preacher's name was Harmon Self. He had the room and his washing and a place at the table three times a day, and he preached at the log church two Sundays in the month and thought himself well fixed.

One evening that fall an old man came up the mountain road on foot. He was a preacher too, of what persuasion nobody afterward could say. He had a way of walking and a way of standing still that Tidmore liked the minute he saw them, and Tidmore had him in. He fed him the best there was in the house. He saw the state of the old man's clothes and brought out a length of new jeans cloth his wife had woven. *Have this made up and wear it next to you.* He saw the hair down on his collar and sent a boy for the neighbor who barbered. He had his own feather bed carried up to the loft. *You lie on this.* Then he asked both preachers to breakfast and went to bed himself.

Harmon Self had watched the whole of it from his place at the table. He had eaten at that table two years, and nobody had ever sent for a barber.

That night he climbed to the loft where the old man lay and stood over him with a candle. *You would do better to eat dung than eat at Tidmore's table,* he said. *You would do better to tear your hair out with a wool card than have it cut by his barber. You would do better to go naked than wear his jeans. You would do better to lie on the bare ground than in his bed.*

The old man made him no answer. He thought, Let this fool not come to ruin on my account. Before day he got up and went on down the far side of the mountain toward the river, wherever it was he was going.

In the morning Self swept the yard and drew the water. When it came time to wake the company he tapped on the loft ladder with one fingernail and came away. *Where is our brother?* Tidmore asked at the table. *Still abed,* said Self. *I have swept and I have drawn water and I have knocked for him, and he has slept through every bit of it.*

Tidmore knew better than that, and knew about what must have been said. There was nothing to say that would mend it. He gave Self his breakfast as he did every morning, and then he had his wife fill the dinner bucket with the best of what was left, ham and biscuit and a jar of gravy, and he said, *If you come up with him on the road, give him this.*

Self took the bucket. He thought, If that old man gets one more taste of this cooking he will be here till Judgment. Half a mile down the road he turned it over in the ditch. Then he went on to the forks and looked for the old man, and did not find him.

That was the deed. The old people on the Mountain said a man could pray twenty years on top of a thing like that and not cover it, and they said Harmon Self did.

II. The Table Rock

1857 *to* 1912

The boy the Mountain called Jim Buck was born the next spring, in a house with plenty in it: four mules, a full smokehouse, bees. Whose house it was depends on who is telling. Some say Self's own. Some say Self died that winter with his face to the wall, and the child came to people named Buck across the gulf who had never heard of him.

From the time he could walk he would not lie in a bed and he would not eat at a table. He ate off the ground. A good many children on the Mountain ate a little clay out of the chimney, and nobody thought much about it. This one ate from the ground behind the smokehouse, where the family went, there being no such thing as a privy on Sand Mountain then, and it was not only the ground he ate. His mother and father said, *He is a baby. He doesn't know any better.* He got older and it was the same. By then he would not keep a stitch on him, summer or winter, and he slept in the yard like a dog. His people said, *He is not fit to live in a house. He is fit for those sanctified folks and nothing else.*

The sanctified band were camped that year on the brow, a dozen men who had come out from all the churches and went barefoot and bareheaded and begged their meal in the settlement. They took him. Their way of taking a man was to stand him in a sawpit up to his neck, lay planks across his collarbones and sit on the planks, and pull out his hair with a pair of wool cards. His mother and father gave the band a dinner for it and went home.

The next morning the band said, *Come on, we are going down to the settlement.* He said, *You go. I will stay here.* They sent food back up to him and he would not touch it. *I don't need it. I get my own. Where? Right here.* It was the same the second day and the third. On the fourth, two of them made as if to go with the rest and then lay down in the laurel and watched. When he thought he was alone he went to the trench the camp used, lifted a board, got down in it, and ate with both hands.

When the band heard, they said, *If the Methodists get hold of this they will tell it that this is what we live on. He is not fit for us either.* And they put him out.

After that he took up at the table rock back of Shiloh church. It was a flat shelf of sandstone on the brow, in the woods on the men's side, with a basin worn in the top of it, and for want of any other place it was where men went on meeting days. By night he ate there. By day, when anybody came into the woods, they found a man with a guano sack about his middle, leaning one hand on the rock and standing on one leg with the

other foot set against his knee, and his mouth wide open to the wind that came up out of the gulf.

Brother, why do you stand with your mouth open that way?

I am a wind-eater. I take no other food.

And why the one foot?

If I was to set both feet down, this mountain would shake. I don't sit and I don't lie down. I have stood since I came here.

People will mostly believe a thing that is said to them plainly by a man who asks nothing for it. Before long both ends of the Mountain were stirred up over him. *We never had such a man as that. There never was one.* Every fourth Sunday, when there was preaching at Shiloh and singing after it, they carried a plate out to the rock. He would not have it. *I eat the wind. If I took any other thing it would undo all I have done.* They begged him. *Don't do us that way. If a man like you would take one bite from our hands, it would be the making of us for as long as we live.* In the end he would reach down and pull a straw of broom sedge and touch the tip of it to their sorghum or their butter or their honey, and lay the tip of the straw on the tip of his tongue. *Go on, now. That will do you.*

So he lived, month after month, for fifty-five years, counting from the day he could walk. He went naked or the next thing to it. He ate filth. He pulled out his hair, and he slept on the ground when there was nobody to see.

III. The Glass

Shiloh crossroads · the fourth Saturday in July, 1912

The State Board of Health sent a dispensary up the Mountain that summer, a doctor and a microscopist in a hired hack, with a tin trunk of capsules and a stack of bulletins for the schoolchildren to carry home. The doctor was a Dr. Anders from below Montgomery. The microscopist was a Miss Lura Hyatt, twenty-three years old, whose people were from the far end of the Mountain. She had been as yellow as a gourd herself until she was sixteen. Then a doctor at Albertville gave

HER THYMOL, AND AFTER IT SHE FINISHED SCHOOL IN TWO years and went down to the State laboratory to learn the glass.

She saw him at sunup from the hack as they came along the brow: a man on a rock, on one leg, the color of tallow. She had been that color. She knew what he ate as surely as if she had stood and watched him. She thought, If that one would carry a tin box to the table, the whole Mountain would.

They set up at the schoolhouse across the road from the church. People had been told from the pulpit, and they came. They came in wagons and on mules and on foot, with the specimen in a snuff tin or a baking-powder can with the name penciled on a scrap of paper, and they stood in the yard and waited their turn and looked at the worms in the bottle on the exhibit table. Miss Hyatt sat at the window with the light on her mirror and did a hundred and forty slides. She called the doctor over for the first few, and after that she only wrote down a mark, and the mark was nearly always the same one.

At the end of the day she said, *I am going up to the one on the rock.*

You cannot mean to go up there, said Dr. Anders.

I do mean to.

She went when the shadows were getting long. On her way a shower came over out of a sky with nothing in it. It rained hard on the brow for about as long as it takes to draw a bucket of water, and quit. When she came through the trees, the table rock, which had not been clean in fifty years, was as clean as a washed plate.

She made a little noise with her foot. *Jim Buck.*

He thought, Who is this that calls me Jim Buck? *Who is it?*

It's me. One that has done without.

What do you want?

Give me a place to stay tonight.

There is no place to stay here.

Don't do that way. Just the one night. Like goes to like. People go to people and brutes to brutes, and one that has done without goes looking for another.

Have you done without?

I have.

Then where is your sack, and your staff, and your Testament?

I have got all of them. They are a trouble to tote from place to place, so I keep them inside, and I take them with me when I go.

That put him out. *So you aim to take them with you when you go.*

Never mind that. Tell me where I can stay.

There is no place.

Under the brow, not fifty steps off, there was a rockhouse, a dry shelf of sand with the bluff hanging over it. She pointed. *Does anybody stay in that?*

Nobody.

Then let me have it.

Suit yourself.

IV. Three Lights

The rockhouse · that night

She spread her quilt on the sand and lay down. In the fore part of the night four lights came along the foot of the bluff, one from each way, and stood at the four sides of the rockhouse, and it was light as far as the far wall of the gulf. Jim Buck saw it from his rock. What light is that? At midnight one came by itself that was brighter than the four. Who is that? Toward day there came one that lit the whole woods, so that a man could have counted the leaves. The old people had a saying about that one, that with one finger he lights one world, and with ten fingers ten. Who can that be?

At daybreak he went down to her. He spoke to her civilly and stood off to one side.

Who was it came to you in the fore part of the night, the four of them?

Four that keep the corners of this country.

What did they come for?

To see was there anything I wanted.

And the one at midnight?

He is over those four. He sat and held the lamp for me.

And the one toward day?

That is the one the preachers holler to.

Are you greater than them, then?

They came to me. I did not go to them.

He studied her. *You are a wonder, girl. I have lived on this rock since before you were born, eating wind and standing up, and in all that time not one soul has ever come to me of a night with so much as a pine knot.*

Jim Buck, she said, *you have fooled the people on this mountain, and now you are trying it on me. For fifty-five years you have eaten filth and lain on the ground and gone naked and torn out your hair. And you have told them, wind is my food, I stand on one foot, I do not sit, I do not lie down. It is all a result. It never was the cause of a thing.*

The result of what?

She told him what an old woman had told her in the schoolyard the day before, while she waited with her snuff tin: the room built onto the house, the old man on the road, the jeans cloth and the barber and the feather bed, the four things said by candlelight, the bucket turned over in the ditch. She did not say whose father it was or whether it was anybody's. She said, *Every one of the four things he wished on that old man, you have done every day you have lived.*

It went into him as she told it. Shame came up in him, and fear at what he had done, and he crouched down on the ground with his arms around his knees. She took off the canvas duster she rode in and tossed it to him, and he put it on. Then he sat down, off to one side of her, on the sand.

She had the glass in its box. She set it on a ledge where the first sun came in, and tilted the mirror. *Bring me some of what you ate last night, on a splinter.* He brought it. She fixed the slide and stood away. *Look.*

He looked a long time. *What are they?*

Eggs. That is what you have been eating since you could walk, and that is what has been eating you. They are in near about every child on this mountain that goes barefoot in the dew back of that church. The ground is full of it. You stood fifty years in the very place it starts. She had one of the school bulletins in her grip. It was made up in questions and answers, like a catechism, so a child could say it over at home, and she said three of them to him.

What is a dirt-eater?
A dirt-eater is a person who has an unnatural appetite, and on this account eats clay, sand, plaster, soot, wood, cloth, or other things not intended for food.

Is dirt-eating the cause of hookworm disease?
It is the result of the disease, not the cause.

Can dirt-eating be cured?
Yes, very easily; by curing hookworm disease.

— Soil Pollution, Questions 40–42

When he raised his eye from the glass he was done with the rock. People who knew him before and after said that was the place it happened, bent over a brass tube in a rockhouse with a girl's coat on.

What do I do?

She put out her right hand to him. *Come on down.*

V. Fourth Sunday

Shiloh church · the next morning

It was the day in the month when the Mountain came with its plates. They came out of the church at noon and carried them back through the trees to the table rock, and there he was, with both feet on the ground, in a canvas coat, like any old deacon in from the field, standing beside a young woman who had a brass tube under her arm.

They talked among themselves. *Which of them is the greater? If it was her, he would have gone down the mountain to her. She came up the mountain to him. So it must be him.*

She heard it. *Jim Buck, settle that for them.*

That is the very thing I would like best to do, he said.

There are people on Sand Mountain today whose grandmothers stood there and saw it. He went up off the ground to the height of a pine tree and called down, *This young woman is my teacher, and I am her scholar,* and came down and bowed to her. He went up again to the height of two

pines, and of three, and so on until he was seven pines high and small against the sky, and each time he said the same thing and came down.

Then he sat down at her feet. Nobody there had ever seen him sit.

The people said, *Lord, what must she know?*

She was not a speaker and she did not make a speech. She said, *All these years he has stood here and taken your sorghum off the tip of a sedge straw one Sunday in the month, and called that serving God. If from today he went hungry one day out of plain sorrow for it, that one day would be worth more. Put all his fifty years of standing together and they are not worth the sixteenth part of what a child knows who has looked down this glass and understood what she saw.*

Then she set the glass on the table rock, in the sun, and let them look, one at a time, the men and then the women and then the children held up to it.

Dr. Anders was out of tin boxes before two o'clock. People went home and got snuff tins. On Monday the schoolyard was full again before the dew was off, and Jim Buck was the first in the line, with that name and no other written for him on a scrap of paper. He took his salts that night and his capsules at six and at eight in the morning, and at noon Eli Tidmore's granddaughter set a place for him, and he ate at a table.

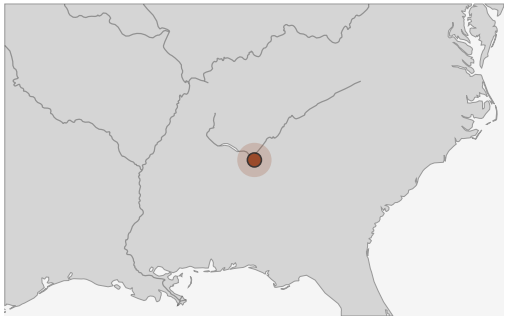
The dispensary went on to the next point. He stayed. The first pit privy on that end of the Mountain was dug that August behind Shiloh church on the women's side, and the second on the men's, a little way off from the table rock, and he dug them both. He lived eleven years more, in overalls and brogans, and dug the pit for nearly every privy between the church and the gulf. When somebody carried his dinner out to where he was working, he climbed up out of the hole, washed his hands, and sat down to it.

Background

The verse

> *Let a fool month after month eat his food (like an ascetic) with the tip of a blade of Kusa grass, yet he is not worth the sixteenth particle of those who have well weighed the law.*
>
> Dhammapada 70, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a resident monk grows jealous when his lay supporter honors a visiting elder with food, a robe, a barber and a bed. He tells the visitor he would do better to eat dung, tear out his hair with a palm comb, go naked and lie on the ground, and next day throws away the meal sent after him. For this he is reborn as Jambuka, who from infancy will eat nothing but excrement and will wear nothing. The naked ascetics take him in and then put him out. He lives at a flat rock used as a latrine, standing on one leg with his mouth open, tells people he eats only wind, and once a month takes their offerings on the tip of a blade of grass. The Buddha asks him for a night's lodging, is refused, and sleeps in a cave nearby, where the Four Great Kings, Sakka and Brahmā visit him with lights. In the morning he tells Jambuka the truth about his life and its cause, tosses him a cloth to cover himself, and teaches him. Jambuka then rises seven palm trees into the air before his admirers to show them who is the teacher. Read the full commentary story, or about the Ājīvikas, the order of naked ascetics he belonged to.



Sand Mountain, Marshall County, Alabama

Sand Mountain, 1912

In 1902 the zoologist Charles Wardell Stiles identified the American hookworm, a parasite half an inch long that enters through bare feet from ground fouled with human waste (the itch it raises was called ground itch, or dew poison) and lives in the bowel on blood. It left millions of Southerners pale, thin and slow, and some of the worst cases craved clay and dirt. From 1909 to 1914 the Rockefeller Sanitary Com-

mission paid for a campaign through the state boards of health. Its field doctors and microscopists held free county dispensaries one day a week at schools and crossroads; people brought specimens in tins, saw the eggs for themselves through the microscope, and were given thymol in capsules with Epsom salts before and after. A visitor quoted in the Commission's report for 1911 said of the crowds, "It looks like the days of Galilee." Kentucky's report for 1912 mentions a young woman among its microscopists. The questions and answers are from Stiles's school circular *Soil Pollution as Cause of Ground-Itch, Hookworm Disease (Ground-Itch Anemia), and Dirt Eating* (1910), the Commission's first publication, which children were told to take home and read to their parents.

Sand Mountain is a broad sandstone plateau in northeast Alabama, a country of small farms, bluffs and rock shelters, where churches commonly had preaching one Sunday in the month and all-day singings from the shape-note books. Alabama's dispensaries reached Marshall County, on the Mountain, in 1912. The Commission's report for that year counted 580 children examined there and half of them infected, and of 226 country homes inspected every one fell in the two lowest classes of its privy index. The Encyclopedia of Alabama has more on the disease in the state. Shiloh church, the table rock and all the people in the story are invented.

After the story of the naked ascetic Jambuka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 70). The original. Scripture from Ch. Wardell Stiles, *Soil Pollution as Cause of Ground-Itch, Hookworm Disease (Ground-Itch Anemia), and Dirt Eating* (Rockefeller Sanitary Commission, 1910). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

5.12

Banked Fire

...everyone is the son of his works.
— Cervantes, Don Quixote, Part I, ch. 4

Así me lo contaron, on the boat beach below San Juan.

I. The Glacis

San Juan, Puerto Rico · November 3, 1625

The Dutch fleet stood out past the Morro on the second of November with every ship but one, and the next morning the governor sent a corporal and eleven men down into the town to see what was left of it.

Lucas Bermejo was one of the eleven. He was eighteen and came from Triana, across the river from Seville, where his father caulked boats. He had landed in Puerto Rico in August with the new governor, Don Juan de Haro, and five weeks later he was inside the Morro with three hundred and thirty men, and the Dutch were in the town, and he had spent his first autumn in the Indies eating cassava bread that came across the bay at night in canoes and listening to cannon. The Dutchman had sent a drum to the gate twice. The second time the message was that if the fort did not surrender he would burn the town. The governor had sent back word that they had courage enough, and wood and stone enough, to build it again. The whole garrison knew the words by evening. The next day the smoke began.

Now it was over. The twelve went out through the gate and down across the glacis, stepping over the Dutch trenches. Lucas had heard about Gaspar Ortiz since his first week. Gaspar was born in San Germán and had been a soldier of the presidio for thirty-one years. He knew

where the rocks were under the water at the harbor mouth, and which of the women in the town sold bad wine, and he saw things. The men said he had once talked with a crow on the Morro at sunrise, and that the crow had answered him.

From the top of the slope the whole town lay open to them. More than a hundred houses had burned, the thatched ones to nothing, the stone ones to their walls. The bishop's house was a shell. The bishop had owned more books than anyone in the island, it was said, and had written some of them, and it was all one grey heap now inside four walls. Smoke still rose here and there from under the ash, thin and blue. Where the wind passed over a heap it showed red underneath for a moment and then went grey again. Beyond the town, on the road from the San Antonio bridge, people were coming back already with mattresses on their heads.

Gaspar stopped at the edge of the glacis. Lucas, behind him, saw his head lift and turn slowly, from the Morro down the whole length of the town to the bridge, the way a man looks along a beam to see if it is true. He stood so for four or five breaths. Then he smiled.

Lucas had buried two men on the Morro that month. He felt the smile like a slap.

What is it?

Not here, said Gaspar. *Ask me tonight at the boats, in front of Antón.* And he went on down into the ash.

II. The Boats

The beach below the town · that evening

ANTÓN'S CANOE LAY ON THE SAND WHERE THE TOWN CAME down to the bay. It was a long dugout of ceiba with a little mast, and it had crossed the bay every night of the siege with cassava and plantains and once a pig, from the Bayamón shore to the rocks under the fort, after Captain Botello's men took back the river. Antón was past seventy. He had come from Luanda as a boy in a Portuguese ship, and he had been free for thirteen years. He kept a clay pot in the bow of the canoe with

COALS IN IT UNDER A LID OF ASH, SO THAT HE COULD LIGHT his pipe anywhere on the water, and he was sitting by it now with his back to a beached boat. Two fishermen were mending a net. A woman was beating ash out of a blanket against a post.

Gaspar sat down. Lucas stood.

This morning, Lucas said, *on the glacis. You told me to ask you here.*

Gaspar took some time with it.

There was a man lying along the town, he said. *His head was on the rocks under the Morro and his body went down the whole length of the town and past the bridge, I could not see how far. The head was a man's head, with a man's beard. The rest of him was a snake. And he was burning. Not the town. Him. The fire started at his head and ran down him to the tail, and then it started at the tail and ran back up to the head, and fire came out of his sides and fell back on him like rain. The town was smoking, and he was lying in it on fire, and his eyes were open.*

One of the fishermen stopped his needle.

I smiled because I am fifty-four, Gaspar said, *and I have heard all my life that there are such beings, and that morning I saw one.*

Like the crow, said the other fisherman.

Like the crow, Gaspar said. He told it for Lucas, since Lucas was new. Some years before, coming off watch on the Morro at sunrise, he had seen one of the big island crows sitting on the parapet over the sea, the kind with the red eyes that talk to each other in the forest like old women. This one was as big as the sentry box. Its tongue hung out of its beak and down the cliff into the surf. Gaspar had asked it what it had done, and it had answered him in a voice like a parrot's, very clearly.

Three mouthfuls, the crow said. *On the feast of San Juan, when the friars fed the poor in their cloister, the women carried home what was left over in their baskets. I was on the convent roof. I took three mouthfuls out of a basket going by. That is all I did.*

Antón had not looked up through any of this. He lifted the lid off his clay pot, took a coal out in the tongs of two sticks, and lit his pipe from it.

I have seen him, he said.

The woman with the blanket stopped beating it.

I saw him the first morning I crossed this bay as a free man. That is thirteen years. I see him most nights when I am out late. He lies the length of the south shore in the dark, from the Bayamón mouth west to Toa, and he burns the way the sergeant says. I never told it. He drew on the pipe. *Who will get into the boat of a man who sees burning men in the water? And the ones who would laugh at it. It goes badly with people who laugh at the dead. I kept quiet for their sake. Now there are two of us who have seen him, so I can say who he is.*

III. The Cross at the River

The Bayamón shore · 1607–1611

In the time when Antón still belonged to a widow on the Calle de la Fortaleza, a man called Hermano Cristóbal put up a cross of two mangrove poles at the mouth of the Bayamón River, on the far side of the bay, and built a hut of palm thatch beside it.

He was a lay hermit in a habit of grey sacking, with the bishop's leave. People said he had been a sugar master on Hispaniola, the man who stands over the boiling coppers and says when the syrup is ready, and that one morning in the middle of the grinding he had put down his ladle and walked out of the boiling house and kept walking. He did not preach. In four years nobody heard him say more than a few words together. He lived on what he was given, and every morning he crossed to the town in Antón's canoe and stood in doorways with a gourd until it had something in it, and at noon Antón carried him back.

Antón's widow hired him out to work the canoe and took four reales a day from him, and whatever he earned over the four reales was his. In the first year after the hermit came, the crossings doubled. In the second they doubled again. Every morning and every evening the canoes went over full. Women went with jasmine and roses from their patios, and with little bottles of orange-flower water, and with candles wrapped in a cloth. Soldiers went, and masons, and a mulata who sold sweets by the cathedral, and once the treasurer's wife in a chair carried by two men who had to wade. They knelt or sat by the cross in the sand for an hour, and the hermit sat by his hut, and nobody spoke much. Then they came home.

Antón would say only that they came home quieter than they went. He charged them a quarter real each way, and he put it in a jar.

Between the landing and the cross lay the ground of Bartolomé Pérez, an islander from La Palma in the Canaries, who grew cassava and ginger there with his wife and his two sons. Ginger was money in those years. The fleet took it to Seville, and the Dutch and English ships that were not supposed to be on the coast took it too, and paid better. Bartolomé had cleared that ground himself and he had put every real he had into the ginger.

The path went through it. At first the people kept to the path. Then there were too many for the path, and they walked the rows. Ginger is a cane no higher than a man's knee, with a soft stalk, and a foot breaks it. Bartolomé put up a fence of stakes, and people climbed over it carrying their candles. He stood at the landing in the evenings and asked them, with his hat in his hand, not to walk on his ginger. They said yes, of course, and walked on it. He asked the hermit, and the hermit looked at him a long while and said nothing, as he said nothing to anyone. He went to the alcalde, and the alcalde said it was a matter of devotion and the bishop's affair. He went to the bishop's secretary, who said it was a matter of land and the alcalde's.

In the spring of 1611, at the time of the morning crossings, he stood at the edge of his field and watched them come up out of the canoes, sixty or seventy people, and go through the ginger to the cross. He thought, if that hut were not there they would not come.

That morning Antón carried the hermit over to the town as usual. When they had gone, Bartolomé went to the hut. He broke the clay water jar and the two gourd bowls, and he set fire to the thatch.

At noon Antón brought the hermit back. They saw the smoke from halfway across. When the canoe touched, the hermit stepped out and walked up to the place where his hut had been and looked at the ashes. Then he turned around and gave Antón the gourd from the morning, which had a piece of cassava bread in it and some salt fish, and he went up the river path into the woods toward the hills. Antón called after him. He raised one hand without looking back.

IV. The Ginger

The same evening

At sundown the canoes crossed full, Antón's and five others. People got out with their flowers and their candles and went up through the ginger, and stopped. The cross was black. The hut was a ring of ash with the shards of the water jar in it.

Where has the brother gone? they said. *Who did this?*

Bartolomé had come down to watch them find it. He was standing among them. He said it plainly, the way a man says his name to the notary.

I burned it. Now you can stop walking on my ginger.

Somebody said, *Take him.* Somebody else said, *Because of him we have lost the brother.* And they took him. They had in their hands what people have in their hands at a landing at evening. Paddles, and the stakes of his own fence, and stones from the river mouth. Women who had come with roses. Antón would not say how long it was. He said only that he had a paddle in his hand, and that he would say no more about his paddle, and that he had been sorry for it every day since. They left Bartolomé on the sand between his ginger and the water. His wife found him there by lantern. He died before morning.

The alcalde wrote that a farmer had been killed at night by persons in a crowd, and no person was named. The widow sold the ground that summer to a man from Toa and went back to the Canaries with her sons. Nobody farmed it. Nobody crossed in the evenings any more, either. Antón's jar stopped filling.

But there was enough in it. In the spring of 1612 he took it to his widow, and she named a price, and he paid it, and the notary wrote out the paper. The next morning he put the paper inside his shirt and pushed off to cross the bay for the first time as his own man, and halfway over, in the grey before sunrise, he saw Bartolomé lying along the south shore.

His head was on the sand where we left him, Antón said. *Every morning since. Every night.*

V. Under the Ash

The boat beach · that night, 1625

It was dark by then. Up the slope the town was dark too, except where the ash heaps breathed.

Fourteen years he has been dead, said Lucas. *He did one thing.*

Antón knocked his pipe out on the side of the canoe.

Milk, he said. *You draw it from the goat in the morning and it is sweet. At noon it is sweet. You would swear by it. Then in the evening it has turned, all at once, and you never saw it turn.* He put the lid of ash back over his coals with two fingers. *And this. Look up there. The Dutchman lit that town twelve days ago. A child could walk across it in the daytime. It is all grey. Put your hand in it.*

Nobody spoke for a while. The fishermen had given up their net. Then Lucas, who could not read, said a thing he had heard read aloud the winter before in a wineshop in Triana, out of the book about the mad gentleman of La Mancha that everybody was laughing at. A rich farmer was flogging his shepherd boy, and the madman rode up and stopped it, and the farmer said the knight had no business with him, and the madman answered him.

> *"That matters little," replied Don Quixote; "there may be Haldudos knights; moreover, everyone is the son of his works."*
>
> *— Cervantes, Don Quixote, Part I, ch. 4*

And what happened to the boy? said the woman with the blanket.

The madman rode away, said Lucas, *and the farmer tied the boy back up to the tree and flogged him twice as hard.*

Antón laughed for the first time that night. *There,* he said. *You see. Later.*

• • •

Before light Lucas went across with him for cassava, because the fort was still hungry and the governor wanted bread before stone. Antón lifted the

ash off his clay pot in the bow, and under it the coals were red, as they had been all night, and he blew on one until it brightened and lit his pipe from it. Lucas looked along the south shore and saw nothing there but the shore.

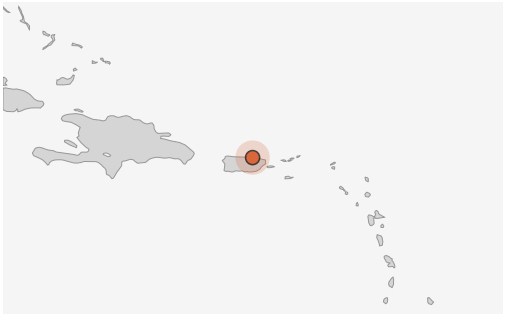
They came in at the Bayamón mouth. Nobody had planted the ground behind the landing in fourteen years, and the sea grape and the bush had taken most of it. But all through the bush, in rows that were no longer quite rows, there were ginger canes standing knee high, green, the way ginger comes back from any piece of root left in the ground. Lucas stepped on one getting out of the canoe and smelled it, hot and sharp, on his heel all the way up to the farms.

Background

The verse

> *An evil deed, like newly-drawn milk, does not turn (suddenly); smouldering, like fire covered by ashes, it follows the fool.*
>
> Dhammapada 71, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, coming down from Vulture's Peak with the elder Lakkhaṇa, smiles, and will say why only in front of the Buddha: he has seen a peta, a suffering ghost, with a man's head and a snake's body many leagues long, burning from head to tail and from tail to head. On another day he sees a crow-ghost whose tongue is five leagues long, and it tells him its whole offense was three mouthfuls of food carried home from a meal given to monks. The Buddha confirms the snake-ghost, saying he saw it himself on the day of his awakening and kept silent out of compassion for those who would not have believed him. Then he tells its past: a farmer near Benares, whose field was trampled by the crowds going morning and evening with perfumes and garlands to a solitary awakened one in a leaf hut by the river, broke the hermit's bowls and burned his hut while he was away on his alms round; the hermit simply went elsewhere; and when the crowd came and found the ashes, the farmer said aloud that he had done it, and they beat him to death with sticks and stones. A bad deed, the Buddha says, is like milk, which does not turn the moment it is drawn. Read the full commentary story, or about Moggallāna.



San Juan, Puerto Rico

San Juan, 1625

On September 24, 1625, a Dutch fleet of seventeen ships under Boudewijn Hendricksz sailed into San Juan Bay. The townspeople fled inland over the San Antonio bridge while Governor Juan de Haro, who had held office less than a month, shut himself into the Castillo San Felipe del Morro with about 330 men. The Dutch occupied the empty town and besieged the fort for weeks; Captain Andrés Botello's militia retook the Bayamón River and supplies reached the Morro again. When Hendricksz threatened to burn the town, de Haro answered that they had courage enough and wood and stone enough to build again. From October 22 the Dutch burned more than a hundred houses, including the palace and library of the poet-bishop Bernardo de Balbuena, then were driven back to their ships and sailed on November 2, leaving one ship behind. See Battle of San Juan (1625).

In the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries ginger flourished on Puerto Rico and Hispaniola, and it found a better market in England and the Low Countries than in Castile, so that much of it went to English and Dutch traders outside the Spanish fleet system (see Bethany Aram, "Caribbean ginger and Atlantic trade, 1570–1648"). The white-necked crow, a big red-eyed forest crow whose voice is more like a parrot's babble than a crow's caw, lived on Puerto Rico until it was hunted out early in the twentieth century. Cervantes published the first part of *Don Quixote* in 1605, and copies went to the Indies with the fleet that same spring; the line Lucas remembers is quoted from John Ormsby's 1885 translation. Gaspar, Lucas, Antón, Hermano Cristóbal, Bartolomé Pérez and the cross at the river are invented.

After the story of the snake peta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 71). The original. Quotation from Cervantes, *Don Quixote*, tr. John Ormsby (1885). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

5.13

A Thousand Stamps

> *He that binds up a stone in a sling, is like one that gives glory to a fool.*
> *— Proverbs 26:8 (Septuagint)*

Ovako sam čuo, on Gwinn Avenue.

I. The Oak

Lead, South Dakota · Christmas Eve by the old calendar, January 6, 1917

Two men went up the ridge above the Open Cut before daylight to cut the Christmas oak. Marko Radulović was past fifty and had been a timberman in the Homestake for twenty-six years. Luka was nineteen and had come from Grahovo in the spring. Oak does not like that altitude, but there was a draw on the south side where a few had held on, and the Montenegrins and the Serbs of Gwinn Avenue had been going there on this morning since before Luka was born.

They did it properly. Marko took off his cap and wished the tree good morning and a happy Christmas Eve, and threw a handful of wheat at it, and cut on the east side so it would fall toward the sunrise. He did not let it touch the ground. Then they started down with the log on their shoulders, Marko in front.

It was fourteen below. Under them the town lay in its gulch with every lamp lit, and along the hillside stood the mills, one above another, steaming from every joint. The noise came up to meet them.

There were a thousand and twenty stamps in the Homestake mills that winter. A stamp is an iron shoe on the end of an iron stem, the whole thing as heavy as a saddle horse. A turning cam lifts it the length of a hand and lets it drop on wet ore in an iron box, and then lifts it again.

They stood in rows of five, and the rows stood in ranks down the length of each mill, and each one fell better than eighty times a minute, day and night and Sunday. The rock went in at the top of the hill in pieces the size of a man's head and came out at the bottom as gray water. People in Lead did not hear it. It was only when a mill shut down for a broken shaft that the whole town woke at once in the dark and lay wondering what was wrong. Babies born there could not sleep in the country. Men who went home to the old villages wrote back that the quiet had made them ill.

Luka had been in Lead eight months and still heard it. He heard it in his teeth. He was a mucker on the eight-hundred level, three dollars and a half for eight hours, and he had sent home more money since May than his father had seen in his life. He had not yet decided what he thought of the place.

Where the path came out of the trees above the highest mill, Marko stopped. Luka, behind him under the heavy end, saw his head lift and turn toward the mills. He stood so for the space of three or four breaths, and then he smiled.

It was a small smile and it did not last. Luka thought afterward that it was the look of a man who has been told all his life about some animal, a camel or a whale, and then comes around a corner and finds one standing in the road.

Marko Radulović was not a man who smiled at nothing. He was known on the Avenue for seeing more than other people. He had walked his whole shift out of a stope in 1907 an hour before it burned, and he would not say afterward how he knew.

What is it, striko?

Not here, said Marko. *Ask me tonight, in front of Baba Stana.* And he went on down with the oak.

II. Baba Stana's

Gwinn Avenue · that evening

The Americans called Gwinn Avenue Slavonian Alley. It was Dalmatians and Likans at one end and Montenegrins at the other, Catholic and Orthodox, and in a snowstorm they shoveled each other out. Stana Vukotić had kept a boardinghouse there for thirty years. She was seventy. She had buried a husband out of the mine and raised three sons into it, and fourteen men ate at her table. On paper it was a business. In fact the house was the nearest thing to a church the Orthodox end of the Avenue had, with the nearest priest of their own a long way off by train. She had the icon and the lamp, and she had the Psalter by heart, in the old language, from a childhood of standing through services at Cetinje. Men came to her kitchen with questions they would not have taken to a priest anyway.

She spoke little. When she had said a thing she did not say it again.

At dusk Marko carried the oak in over the threshold, right foot first. Stana threw wheat at him and he wished the house a good evening and a happy Christmas Eve, as is done. There was straw on the floor under the table, for the stable. They laid the log on the fire and poured a little wine on it. When it had caught, they ate the fast-day supper standing up to it at first and then sitting: beans cooked without fat, salt cod, bread, walnuts, dried plums, and red wine that the Dalmatians at the other end of the Avenue had trodden in October from a railroad car of California grapes.

There were fourteen at the table and they were not all friends. Seven years before, the company had shut the whole mine for the winter to break the union, and when it opened again a man could go down only if he signed a card that said he belonged to no union and never would. Some at that table had signed in the first week. Some had held out until their children were hungry and then signed. It was still in the room, most nights. On this night nobody brought it.

Afterward Luka asked.

Striko. This morning above the mills you stopped and smiled. You said to ask you here.

Marko looked at the fire a while.

I saw a man standing in the gulch, he said. *He was as tall as the hill. His feet were down in Gold Run and his head was level with us. And every stamp in the Homestake was coming down on the top of it. All thousand of them, and red, like iron out of the forge. They broke his skull the way they break rock. I saw it open. Then the cams lifted and it closed over whole, and they came down again.* He turned his cup around on the table. *I smiled because I am fifty-three and I had heard there were such beings and never seen one.*

Nobody at the table laughed. It was Marko.

Baba Stana had her hands in her lap.

I have seen him too, she said. *I saw him the first night he stood there. That is twenty-six years, and I have seen him most nights since when I go out for wood. I did not speak of it. If I had told it, there are people who would have called it a lie, and it would have gone badly for them to say so. I kept quiet for their sake. Now there are two of us. So I will tell you who he is.*

III. The Cottonwood

Lead · the summer of 1889

THERE WAS A MAN FROM CUCE NAMED VUKO PEROVIĆ WHO lost the use of his legs in the mine in 1885, when a set of timbers let go. The company gave him a stool. He was to sit at the foot of Mill Street, where the Deadwood road comes into town past the Brick Store, and count the wood wagons going up to the boilers. There was a big cottonwood there, the only real shade in the gulch.

As a boy Vuko had kept goats on the stone above Cuce with a sling. Sitting on that stool all day he found that he could do with a thumb and a finger what he used to do with the sling. He kept a pocket of creek gravel. He could flick a pebble the size of a pea through one leaf of that cottonwood, forty feet up, and not move the leaf beside it.

The children found him out. They came down from every part of town, Cornish and Finn and Italian and ours, and stood around the stool. *Make*

a horse, Vuko. Make a bear. And he would look up into the tree for a while, and then his hand would go, tick, tick, tick, faster than a sewing machine, and bits of green would come spinning down. When he was done the children looked at the ground. The sun came through the holes he had cut and lay on the dust of the road in the shape of a bear. They paid him in bread and plums. One boy brought him half a pasty every noon for a summer. He would do a horse, a bear, an eagle, a goat with a beard. A little Finnish girl asked him once for an elephant, which he had never seen. She drew it for him in the dust with a stick, and he looked at it and looked at the tree, and that noon there was an elephant on the Deadwood road, with a trunk, and the freighters drove their teams around it.

I was cook that year for Mr. Crane, who had charge of all the mills. One noon in July he came down Mill Street on foot and stopped under the cottonwood to wipe his neck. He looked down at his own coat. There was a horse on it, in sunlight, and an eagle on his sleeve.

Whose work is this?

They told him, and he had Vuko carried up to the house.

Now Mr. Crane had a trouble. The company kept a lawyer at Deadwood named Colonel Parmalee, and the Colonel talked. If you said to him good morning, he gave you the history of mornings. Mr. Crane had to sit with him every Thursday at dinner and could not finish a sentence.

Could you put a pint of goat droppings into a man's mouth, Mr. Crane said, *a pellet at a time, without his knowing where they came from?*

I could, sir, said Vuko. *Hang a curtain in the pantry door and seat him facing it.*

I had a nanny goat. I dried the pellets on the stove lid myself, a tin pint of them. On Thursday we set Vuko in the pantry behind the door curtain, and he made a hole in the cloth with the point of my paring knife, and I stood beside him with the coffee and watched.

The Colonel sat down and opened his mouth to begin, and something went into it. He swallowed and went on. He opened it again. Every time that man parted his teeth, for an hour and ten minutes, Vuko put a pellet between them, and the Colonel swallowed each one and never lost his place. When the cup was empty Vuko shook the curtain.

Mr. Crane put down his fork. *Colonel,* he said, *I have been trying for two years to get a word in with you. You have just eaten a pint of goat dung at my table and it has not slowed you down.*

The Colonel shut his mouth. He kept it shut on Thursdays from then on, and Mr. Crane grew quite fond of him.

For that, Mr. Crane gave Vuko a new suit and a chair with wheels and the rents of four company houses for his life, one on each side of the Open Cut, north, east, south and west. The women in the kitchen could not get over it. A lame Montenegrin with four rents. I said to them what is written.

> *It is fit that an observant man and one diligent in his business should attend on kings, and not attend on slothful men.*
>
> *— Proverbs 22:29 (Septuagint)*

I was proud of it. A craft is a good thing, I said. Look at Vuko.

IV. The Pupil

The winter of 1889 *and the summer after*

There was a young man boarding on the Avenue then, a mucker, twenty-two. I will call him Mitar. His mother is dead now and it cannot hurt her. Mitar looked at the four rents and the chair with wheels, and he thought, a cripple got all that by flicking gravel. So he went to Vuko and took off his cap.

Teach me.

I can't do that, friend, said Vuko.

Mitar did not argue. He went to the stove and heated water. All that winter, every night after shift, he came to Vuko's room and washed his feet and rubbed his dead legs with brandy and bear grease from the ankle to the hip. He carried him on his back to the bathhouse on Saturdays. He did this for five months and did not ask again until spring.

And Vuko thought, this boy has been a son to me. He could not go on refusing him. He taught him. Mitar was quick. By June he could put out a candle across the room.

It is written somewhere else, and I did not think of it in time.

> *He that binds up a stone in a sling, is like one that gives glory to a fool.*
>
> *— Proverbs 26:8 (Septuagint)*

You have it all now, Vuko said to him. *What will you do with it?*

Go out and show it.

Show it how?

Drop a cow. Or a man. Something people will talk about.

Vuko was frightened then. He said: *Listen to me. A cow is fifty dollars to the Cornishman who owns her, and he will take it out of you. A man is a thousand to his lodge, and after that a rope for you at Deadwood. You have no fifty dollars. Do not kill anything. If you must throw at something, find a thing that has no mother and no father and nobody to go to the judge for it.*

He meant a stump. He meant a bottle on a fence. I knew Vuko. That is all he ever meant.

Mitar filled his pocket with gravel and went looking. He saw the Cornishman's cow on the hill and thought, she has an owner. He saw a man coming off shift and thought, he has a mother somewhere, and a lodge. He let them both go by. He was careful, you see. He had listened to every word.

In those years there was an old man who lived up Poorman Gulch in a shelter of pine boughs and sod. Nobody knew his name or his country. He did not speak. The Finns said he was a Finn, and the Italians said he was a friar who had been put out of his house for holiness. We called him *Deda*, grandfather, and said he was a man of God, and let it go at that. He came down into town every morning with a lard pail and stood at one back door or another. He never knocked. If you put something in the pail he looked at you, and you felt all day as you feel coming out of church at Easter. If you had nothing, he looked at you the same way and went on. He had been coming for nine years. No woman in Lead baked without

thinking of him. In the big snow of 1888 the men of three lodges dug a path up Poorman to his shelter, and found him sitting in it with no fire, and the snow melted back from the boughs the width of a doorstep all the way around.

On a morning in July he came in by the Deadwood road as always, past the Brick Store, under the cottonwood.

Mitar was sitting on Vuko's old stool. He saw him and thought: *This one. He has no mother and no father. He has no lodge and no country, and nobody will go to the judge. I will try it on him.*

He took a stone the size of a hazelnut and aimed at the right ear. It went in at the right ear and came out at the left.

The old man stopped. He did not put his hand to his head. He bent and set the pail down on the road, on its bottom, carefully, so it would not spill. Then he turned around and went back up the gulch. The widow Niemi was hanging wash on the hillside, and she swore to her death that he passed below her yard a hand's breadth above the road, and his feet left no mark in the dust. He went into his shelter and lay down and did not get up.

V. The Gulch

Poorman Gulch · the next day

BY NOON THE NEXT DAY EVERY KITCHEN IN TOWN KNEW HE had not come. Somebody found the pail under the cottonwood with yesterday's bread in it. So they went up. The Finns and the Cornish and the Italians went, and all of the Avenue, some two hundred people on that goat track, the women with their aprons on.

He was lying on his side on the pine boughs with his hands under his cheek. There was a little blood at each ear. The women began to cry out, each in her own language, and the men took off their caps.

Mitar had come up with the crowd to see what the noise was. He pushed in and looked. He had not known, you understand, that anybody would mind. He said it out loud, in a voice of plain surprise, the way you would say you recognized a horse.

Why, that's the one I met at the cottonwood. I tried my hand on him.

I will not tell you all of it. It is Christmas Eve. The men had come straight off shift and had in their hands what they had. They did it there in the gulch, in front of the shelter, and it did not take long, and no one who was there has ever said which of them it was. I will say that I did not look away, and I have asked forgiveness for that every year since. The coroner came up from Deadwood for the two of them and wrote *persons unknown* twice.

That night I sat up with the old man. We had laid him out in the lodge hall, and I had washed him. At midnight the whistle blew for the change of shift and I went to the door for air.

Mitar was standing in the gulch. He was as tall as the hill. There were six hundred and fifty stamps in the mills that year, and all six hundred and fifty were coming down on the crown of his head, red hot, and his head broke and closed and broke. He did not cry out. He had the same look of surprise.

We buried the old man two days after, in ground the three lodges bought together. Nobody could agree what he was, so the Finns' pastor read over him, and then the Italian priest, and then I said the psalms, since there was no one else on our side to say them. The board had no name on it. The children put the lard pail at the foot, and it stood there until it rusted through.

Mitar the county buried. I went to that one too. There were four of us.

The company has built since then. Every stamp they have added, he has had.

VI. Sparks

Gwinn Avenue · the same night, 1917

THE OAK HAD BURNED HALFWAY THROUGH. OUT PAST THE WINdow, down the hill, the mills went on as they always did, and for once every man at the table heard them.

And Vuko? said Luka.

They told him in his chair. He asked which ear. Then he asked them to wheel him to the bridge, and he emptied his pocket into the creek. He never flicked a stone again, not for any child, though they came and stood around him for a year. He signed the four rents over to the lodge for widows, and he went back to the stool, and he died on it in 1903.

She was quiet a moment.

I was wrong, what I said in Mr. Crane's kitchen. A craft is not a good thing. Nor a bad one. Vuko had that craft for thirty years and it made bears for children and shut one lawyer's mouth. Mitar had it for a day. Whatever a fool learns, he learns to his own hurt. He would have been better off with his shovel.

Then she said the psalm, the two verses, in the old language first and then so the young ones could follow.

> *He has opened a pit, and dug it up, and he shall fall into the ditch which he has made. His trouble shall return on his own head, and his unrighteousness shall come down on his own crown.*
>
> *— Psalm 7:16–17 (Septuagint)*

Nobody spoke. After a time Stana nodded at Luka, because he was the youngest. He got up and took the poker and struck the burning oak as it is struck on that night, so that the sparks went up the chimney in a rush. He said what is said. *As many sparks, so many lambs. As many sparks, so many coins. As many sparks, so much health in this house.* His voice shook a little on it.

Marko went out for wood before bed. He stood in the yard some time, with his back to the house, looking down the gulch. He was not smiling when he came in.

• • •

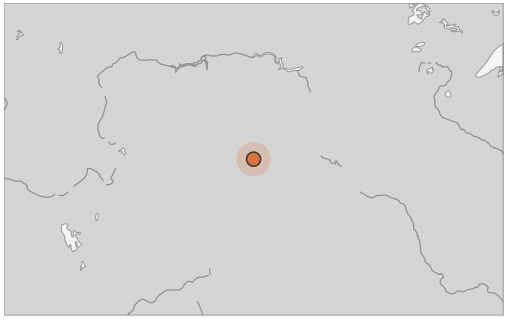
The cottonwood at the foot of Mill Street put out whole leaves every spring after 1890, like any tree. Even so, there were summers when a child crossing the road at noon would stop and call the others. They would stand in a ring and look down, the Cornish and the Finns and ours, at a bear made of sunlight lying in the dust.

Background

The verse

> *And when the evil deed, after it has become known, brings sorrow to the fool, then it destroys his bright lot, nay, it cleaves his head.*
>
> Dhammapada 72, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, coming down from Vulture's Peak with a companion, smiles at something and will explain only in front of the Buddha: he has seen a peta, a suffering ghost, three-quarters of a league tall, whose skull is crushed again and again by sixty thousand blazing hammers. The Buddha says he saw the same being long ago and kept silent out of compassion for those who would not have believed him, and then tells its past. A lame man of Benares could flick pebbles so well that he cut leaves into the shapes of animals for children; a king hired him to flick goat dung into the mouth of a talkative chaplain, and rewarded him with four villages. A man who envied this served the cripple until he was taught the art, was warned to aim only at something "with neither mother nor father," and killed a solitary holy man, a paccekabuddha, with a stone through the ear. The crowd beat him to death. The verse the Buddha draws from it, in the commentary's own reading, is that whatever skill a fool acquires works only to his ruin. Read the full commentary story, or about Moggallāna.



Lead, South Dakota

Lead, South Dakota, 1889–1917

The Homestake Mine at Lead, in the Black Hills, was bought by George Hearst and his partners in 1877 and became one of the richest gold mines in the country. Its ore was crushed in stamp mills that ran around the clock: 650 stamps by the late 1880s and 1,020 at the peak in 1916. Under superintendent Thomas Grier (1885–1914) Lead was a company town with a company store (the "Brick Store"), a free library and kindergarten paid for by Phoebe Hearst, a standard wage of $3.50 a day, and, from

1906, an eight-hour shift; in the winter of 1909–10 the company locked out its whole workforce to break the miners' union and rehired only men who signed a non-union pledge. See Richards and Myers, "An Iron Hand in a Velvet Glove" (*South Dakota History*, 2008). Mr. Crane, Colonel Parmalee and everyone on the Avenue are invented.

Lead's miners came from Cornwall, Finland, Italy, Scandinavia and the South Slav lands of Austria-Hungary and Montenegro. Gwinn Avenue was known as Slavonian Alley, remembered for its Christmas-week open houses and for wine pressed from grapes that came in by iced railroad car. Serbs and Montenegrins keep Christmas by the Julian calendar, so that Christmas Eve falls on January 6. On that morning the men of a household cut a young oak, the *badnjak*, greet it, and bring it in at dusk to burn on the hearth over straw; someone strikes it so the sparks fly and wishes the house as many lambs and coins as there are sparks. The Orthodox Old Testament is the Greek Septuagint, quoted here in Sir Lancelot Brenton's English translation of 1851, in which the psalm is numbered 7:16–17.

After the story of the peta with sixty hammers from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 72). The original. Scripture from the Septuagint, tr. Sir Lancelot C. L. Brenton (1851). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

5.14

Sesame Cake

> *The exclusionist in religion does not see that he shuts the door of heaven on himself, in striving to shut out others.*
> *— Emerson, "Compensation"*

This is how it went around the store, on the west side of Bloomington.

I. The Loft

Bloomington, Indiana · 1978 to 1985

Lowell Sudduth came into the store in the spring of 1978 for a pound of lentils and stayed seven years. He had been a Methodist youth minister in Kokomo until the Sunday he found he could not get through the benediction, and after that he had painted houses. He was thirty-four, long in the leg, with a voice people liked to listen to. Hart Householder took him back to the office and played him the first tape, the woman with the cough and the kitchen clock. Lowell sat through both sides of it without shifting his feet and then asked if there was a second one.

By summer he was living in the loft over the old scale room, where Hart's father had kept the seed-corn records. Hart charged him nothing and fed him. Lowell ran the register on Saturdays, and the rest of the week he ran the sitting.

Before he came it had been six or eight people going down to the paw-paw patch behind the mill whenever they thought of it. Lowell gave it hours. Wednesday night and Sunday morning there was a half hour of tape, then the cassette was turned over and there was a half hour more. Afterward he read one page aloud from a small *Tao Teh King*, the old Legge translation, which he carried in his coat. He built the rain shed

himself out of siding from the mill's own corn crib, and he was particular about who drove a nail in it.

He was good at the work. People came from Spencer and from Nashville on Wednesday nights, and it was Lowell they asked how long before your knees quit hurting. He had a place under the biggest tree at the head of the grove, facing the rest, with the tape machine by his knee. Nobody else touched the machine.

Hart never had people to his table in those years without Lowell at it. If a card went up on the bulletin board about a supper, the card said AND LOWELL. If Hart carried a sack of rice out to somebody's car he said, *Lowell and I thought you could use this.* It went on that way for seven years, and a man gets used to the sound of his own name.

II. Last

The book room · a Friday in late September 1985

The two who came through that fall were her old students, a nurse and a carpenter. They were on their way east and they had been driving since Kansas. Hart went out to the edge of town to meet their car, which he had never done for anybody.

Lowell set up the folding chairs in the book room. He put one at the front, turned sideways, for himself, since somebody would have to say a few words first. Nobody asked him to say them. Hart only said, *These are her people,* and sat down on the floor.

The nurse did most of the talking. She said they were worn out and would keep it short, and it was short. Lowell did not take in much of it. He was watching Hart. In seven years of Wednesday nights he had not seen Hart's face do what it did in that hour.

When it was over Hart got up off the floor.

You'll eat with us tomorrow before you go, he said to the two of them. *Noon, here in the store. Everybody in this room. Bring whoever you came with.*

The nurse nodded. Forty people stood up and started in talking. Hart shook hands all the way to the back of the room, where Lowell was folding chairs and stacking them against the cookbooks.

You come too, Lowell.

Lowell hung a chair on the stack. He had been asked after two strangers and after forty people, some of whom had not sat through one Wednesday.

I've got things to see to tomorrow.

Come and eat.

You go ahead.

Lowell. Come eat with us.

I said I had things.

Hart looked at him a moment. *Well, I hope you'll be there,* he said, and went to find the visitors a bed.

III. The Table

The store · Saturday morning

Lowell did not sleep. A little after five he heard Hart moving below him, and the cooler door, and he thought he would just go and see what was being put on for them. He came down the loft stairs with his coat buttoned.

Hart had laid planks across the grain bins for the length of the store and covered them with bed sheets. There was a crock of pinto beans and a pan of cornbread the size of a door. There was brown rice with walnuts, and tabouli, and the last tomatoes sliced on a platter, and a whole wheel of cheese from the Amish in Daviess County. There were six round loaves, and apple butter, and honey in the comb, and a persimmon pudding. At the far end he had set a dishpan of pawpaws, picked up that morning out of the wet grass. Two women from the Tuesday quilters were slicing bread. A farmer from over by Stanford had come in with cider and stayed to watch.

Sit down, Lowell. There's coffee.

I won't sit. I'm on my way out.

He walked down the planks and looked at all of it, taking his time, like a man going over a car he does not intend to buy.

It's a fine table, Hart. There's only the one thing you've left off.

What's that?

Sesame cake.

Hart's father had sold cake in that building for forty years. That was the trade's word for it. Linseed cake, soybean cake and cottonseed cake were the hard slabs left over when the oil has been pressed out of the seed, and they were sold by the hundredweight to put weight on hogs. Sesame makes a cake like the rest. The farmer from Stanford knew what had been said, and so did the two women. Lowell had called the man a feed dealer at his own table.

Hart laid down the bread knife.

My dad had a customer once who went down to the fair at Louisville and brought home a prize bantam hen. She took up with a crow. He swore to this. She hatched one chick out of it, and when that chick tried to crow like a rooster it said caw, and when it tried to caw like a crow it said cock-a-doodle-doo. He wiped his hands on his apron. *Two people drove in here last night with everything she ever gave them, and they laid it out for anybody to pick up. You had all night to turn it over. And what comes out of your mouth this morning is sesame cake.*

You're making fun of me in front of people, Lowell said. *It's your store, Hart. I'll get out of it.*

I am not making fun of you. Stay where you are. It's a good patch down there, and the loft is yours, and your dinner, as long as this roof holds.

It's your store. I'll go.

Stay, Lowell.

It's your store.

Where will you go?

I'm going out there. I'm going to see her.

Nobody from the store had ever seen her. All any of them had was a box number and the name on the back of a cancelled check.

Then tell her all of it, Hart said. *What you said and what I said, both. I won't be surprised to see you back here.*

IV. Thirty Days

Indianapolis to Weed, California, and back · October

Greyhound sold a pass in those years called the Ameri-pass, good for all the riding a person could stand in seven days, or fifteen, or thirty. Lowell bought the thirty-day one at the depot in Indianapolis out of the house-painting money he kept in a coffee can. It was cheaper than two tickets, and he did not know how long he would be. He did not expect to use it up.

It was three nights sitting up. St. Louis, Kansas City, Denver, Salt Lake, Reno, Sacramento, and then north to a lumber town called Weed, where the bus let him down in sight of the mountain. He spent the three nights on his account of things. There were the seven years and the shed and the Wednesdays, and who had built what, and who had said what first. By Salt Lake he had it so that nobody could have found a hole in it.

He walked and thumbed the nine miles to Mount Shasta and stood in the post office until a young man with a key opened the right box.

I'm from Householder's, in Indiana.

The young man looked at him, and at the grip. *You'd better come on, then,* he said.

She had a small house on Alder Street. He knew the cough before he saw her, and then the clock. She was past seventy, in a housedress and a grey cardigan, and she did not get up. He told it standing. He told it the way it had gone, since Hart had said to, and it did not sound in her kitchen the way it had sounded on the bus.

That man has kept his word for fifty years and fed everybody that came up his road, she said. *You sleep in his loft. And you stood at his table, in front of his company, and called him a feed man. You were the small one in that room, Mr. Sudduth, and you tried to make him small. Go back and ask his pardon.*

That was the whole of it. The young man gave him a plate of beans on the back step and walked him out to the highway.

Three more nights. He came into the store with the grip still in his hand and Hart was at the register.

Hart, it was my fault. All of it. There, I've said so. Now forgive me and let's be done with it.

Hart looked at him for some time.

No, he said. *I don't believe I will.*

Lowell had twenty-three days left on the pass and he spent three of them going straight back. He was hot the whole way. He had gone two thousand miles and said it, and the man would not have it, and what more was there? He said so in her kitchen. She heard him out. She knew that Hart would forgive him, and she knew what it would take, and she did not tell him.

Well, she said, *you had better go on back, then,* and got up to see to something on the stove.

So he went back. They say he got as far as the depot in Indianapolis and stood under the departures board for an hour, and could not find one thing to say to Hart that he had not said already. Then he got on the westbound.

By that time the drivers knew him. One out of Salt Lake said, *You again,* and held the door. Somewhere in Kansas, the third time through it, he had quit working on his account. He had gone over it so often there was nothing left on it. At night in Nevada there is nothing in a bus window but your own face. He slept against the glass with his mouth open like everybody else. A woman with two children used his shoulder from Cheyenne to Rock Springs, and he let her. He ate out of machines.

When he came up Alder Street that time he had crossed the country five times in seventeen days. He needed a shave, and he had no case to make.

V. Remnants

Alder Street, Mount Shasta · the middle of October

SHE LOOKED AT HIM IN THE DOOR.

Come in and sit down, Mr. Sudduth.

It was the first time she had asked him to sit. The young man, whose name was Andy, put a cup in front of him.

Mr. Tibbets next door is going east to see his daughter in Dayton, she said, *and he doesn't like to ride alone. You go along with him as far as Indiana.*

He said he would.

Now listen. A man who has sat down to be quiet has no business holding a deed to it. My shed. My Wednesday night. My machine. My Hart. Once you say mine over a thing like that, everything you sat down to be rid of comes back and puts on weight.

She had a book by her on the table, an old one, the back of it mended with tape. She did not have to hunt for the place.

> *The exclusive in fashionable life does not see that he excludes himself from enjoyment, in the attempt to appropriate it. The exclusionist in religion does not see that he shuts the door of heaven on himself, in striving to shut out others.*
>
> *— Emerson, "Compensation"*

That one is mine, she said. *Andy says you carry one of your own. Read me the place about the tiptoes.*

He had read it aloud in the shed perhaps forty times. He took the little book out of his coat and read it to her.

> *He who stands on his tiptoes does not stand firm; he who stretches his legs does not walk (easily). (So), he who displays himself does not shine; he who asserts his own views is not distinguished; he who vaunts himself does not find his merit acknowledged; he who is self-conceited has no superiority allowed to him. Such conditions, viewed from the standpoint of the Tao, are like remnants of food, or a tumour on the body, which all dislike.*
>
> *— Tao Teh King 24, tr. James Legge*

He had stopped at the remnants of food, and she had waited, and he had gone on to the end.

You've been reading that to other people for seven years, she said.

Yes, ma'am.

It's a good book.

Mr. Tibbets was seventy-one and had been a brakeman on the McCloud River Railroad. He was hard of hearing. He had never sat still on purpose in his life and had never heard one of the tapes, though they were copied in the garage twenty feet from his bedroom window. He carried a cardboard suitcase and a sack of sandwiches, and from Weed to Reno he told Lowell about log trains. He offered him half of everything he had. In the depot at Salt Lake he came back from the newsstand with a sesame bar, broke it, and held out the bigger piece.

Lowell looked at it. Then he laughed, which he had not done in a month, and ate it.

VI. The Chair by the Door

Bloomington · the end of October, and after

THEY WALKED IN FROM THE HIGHWAY, THE TWO OF THEM. Hart was on the loading dock with a sack of rice on his shoulder. Lowell stopped at the foot of the steps where Hart could see him and took off his cap. Mr. Tibbets stood beside him holding the suitcase and looked the mill over with interest.

Hart. You asked me last and I couldn't stand it. I came down that morning to spoil your table, and I said the meanest thing I could find, in your father's own building. I'm sorry for it. I'm asking you to forgive me.

Hart let the sack down.

That's forgiven, Lowell. That's gone. And I had no call to bring out that crow in front of people. If I did you wrong, you forgive me.

Yes.

Who's this?

Mr. Tibbets. He's going on to Dayton.

Not until he eats, said Hart.

Lowell kept to what she had told him. It did not take long. The ones who sat near him that month say only that some time before the first hard frost it was finished in him, and that you could tell by the fact that there was nothing left to step on. You could ask him first or last, or forget

to ask him. He read the page from the little book if somebody handed it to him. Whoever sat nearest the machine turned the tape over.

Two summers later Hart signed the patch away to a board, and Lowell would not be on it. When the card went up about the bread truck he said he had been to Alder Street, and somebody ought to mind the store.

Hart put a tin of halvah by the register that winter, next to the shoebox of tapes, with a card on it in his own printing. SESAME CAKE. ASK LOWELL. It sold steadily. People who asked got the story of the crow, told against himself, with both noises.

His old place under the big tree stayed empty a while, and then somebody's child took it over. In the shed, in cold weather, there was a folding chair just inside the door, in the draft. It had always gone to whoever came last. Lowell was usually the first one down the hill, and he took that one.

Background

The verses

> *Let the fool wish for a false reputation, for precedence among the Bhikshus, for lordship in the convents, for worship among other people!*
>
> Dhammapada 73, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *"May both the layman and he who has left the world think that this is done by me; may they be subject to me in everything which is to be done or is not to be done," thus is the mind of the fool, and his desire and pride increase.*
>
> Dhammapada 74, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The monk Sudhamma lived at Macchikāsaṇḍa in the mango grove that the householder Citta had given, and Citta never invited anyone without naming him. When the two chief disciples came, Citta heard Sāriputta teach, invited the visitors for the next day's meal, and only then turned to invite Sudhamma, who was stung at being asked last and refused three times. Early next morning he went to look over the food all the same, would not sit down, and remarked that only one thing was missing: sesame cake. Citta answered with the tale of a chick hatched from a hen and a crow, which cawed when it meant to crow and crowed when it meant to caw. Sudhamma said, "This is your residence; I will depart," refused three times to stay, and walked the thirty leagues to the Buddha, who put the blame wholly on him and sent him

back to ask pardon. Citta refused it. The Buddha, knowing what was needed, let him make the long journey once more without advice, and when he came back with his pride worn down gave him a companion, warned him against thinking "this dwelling is mine, this disciple is mine," and spoke the verses. Sudhamma asked pardon in Citta's sight, and Citta gave it and asked his in turn; within a few days Sudhamma was an arahat. Only then did Citta set out to see the Buddha himself, which is the journey told in *The Bread Truck*. Here is the full commentary story; the sesame cake and the crow are given at length in the monastic code, Cullavagga I.18. More about Citta.

Bloomington, Indiana, and Mount Shasta, California

Indiana to California by bus, 1985

Greyhound introduced the unlimited-mileage Ameripass in 1972, and for decades it was how people without money crossed the country; in the 1980s it was sold for seven, fifteen or thirty days. A rider going west from Indianapolis went by way of St. Louis, Kansas City, Denver, Salt Lake City and Reno to Sacramento, and changed there for the bus north to Weed, the old lumber town under Mount Shasta. The McCloud River Railroad hauled logs and lumber around the mountain's south side from 1897. Hart's remark at the table turns on a feed-trade word: press cake, or oil cake, is the solid left when oil is pressed from linseed, soybeans, cottonseed or sesame, and it is sold as livestock feed. The sweet he later puts by the register is halvah, made of ground sesame.

Mrs. Varnum reads from Emerson's essay "Compensation" (1841), in the same volume as the "Self-Reliance" she reads from in *The Bread Truck*. Lowell's pocket book is the *Tao Teh King* in the 1891 translation of the Scottish missionary and Oxford professor James Legge, long out of copyright and often reprinted. Lowell Sudduth, Mr. Tibbets, the store and Alder Street are invented, as they were in the earlier story.

After the story of the elder Sudhamma from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 73–74). The original. Quotations from Ralph Waldo Emerson, "Compensation" (*Essays: First Series*, 1841), and the *Tao Teh King*, tr. James Legge (1891). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

5.15

The Heavenly Road

You may talk of my name as much as you please,
And carry my name abroad,
But I really do believe I'm a child of God
As I walk in de heavenly road.
— "The Heavenly Road"

The way it was raised in the praise house, on St. Helena Island.

I. The Pan of Rice

Sandy Field plantation, St. Helena Island, South Carolina · 1854

There was a praise house at Sandy Field, as there was on every cotton place on the island, a board cabin at the end of the street where the people met three nights in the week. The one who led it was a man called Daddy Titus. He hoed his task like anybody. But it was known from Lands End to Coffin Point that if you were down in the valley, hunting for that thing and not finding it, Titus was the one to carry your dreams to.

On Sunday evenings he went down the street from door to door with a basket, for the sick and for burying, and each cabin put in what it had, a handful of grits, an egg, a copper. At the far end lived an old man named Mingo, who had been bought onto the place in the same lot with Titus's father and had outlived his strength. He drew half a peck and had no garden anymore. When he heard the basket coming he thought, That is my own boy at the door, and I have not got one thing to put in. He doesn't know how poor I am. He could not look him in the face. He went round behind the chimney and stood there until Titus had gone by.

The next Sunday he hid again. He told himself, The first thing I get hold of, I will give him. It was a long while coming.

That winter an old woman died on the next place. At the sitting-up they handed round what the family had, something to eat and a bit of cloth, as the custom was, and Mingo was given a pan of rice boiled soft and a square off a new head-handkerchief. He carried both home, and on the way he thought, This is what I will give Titus.

Titus was on his knees in the pines at that hour, where he went by himself to pray. He got up. Mingo has come by something, he thought, and wants me. I had better go. He took his own pan and went and stood at the old man's door.

When Mingo saw who it was, his heart was satisfied. He made his manners and brought him in and set him on the one stool, and he took up the rice and began to turn it into Titus's pan. When half was in, Titus laid his hand over the top.

Son, there is but the one helping here. Make me glad in the next world, not in this one. I want to give it all and keep none back. And he turned in the whole of it. Titus ate it there in front of him. When he was through, Mingo gave him the handkerchief, and bowed, and said, *Let me come to what you came to.*

So be it, said Titus. He thanked him and went home.

There is a saying that what a poor man gives out of an empty hand makes him glad past measuring, and it was so with Mingo. From that night his mind was easy, and he loved Titus for all the days he had left. They were not many. He was laid down in January.

II. Titus's Name

1855 to the spring of 1862

Ten moons after Mingo was laid down, a boy was born to Rina, wife of Bacchus the boat carpenter, who kept the best cabin on the street and stood by the praise house and by Titus through everything. The women counted on their fingers and looked at one another and let it alone.

While she was carrying him a craving came on her. *I want to boil rice soft, with milk and molasses, and feed it to Daddy Titus and every elder on the front bench, and not quit. And I want to tie the seeker's knot on my head again, the way I wore it when I was a girl in the valley, and sit on the back bench with my pan, and eat what the elders leave.* Her people said, *That is a praying kind of craving,* and they did it for her. She knotted the handkerchief over her forehead and sat on the last bench and ate what was left, and the craving went off. The old women said that knot was the sign the child would seek young.

On the day they named him they washed him before light and laid him in the new blanket. At Sandy Field a pair of blankets came to a house every few years, at Christmas, out of the master's hand, and for most houses that was the whole of their wealth. This was the new one. The child lay in it and looked at Titus, and it is told that he knew him. When they took him up to carry him to be blessed, he had hooked his little finger in the blanket and it came up with him. *His finger is caught,* they said, and went to free it, and he screamed. *Let him be. Don't make him cry.* They carried him blanket and all. When they held him down toward Titus he let go, and the blanket fell at Titus's feet.

Nobody said, He is a baby and doesn't know what he is doing. His people said, *Daddy, take what the child gives you. And bless your servant, that has honored you with the best thing in his house.*

What is he to be called?

He is to be called for you.

Then he is Titus.

His mother said in herself, Whatever this one wants, I will not stand in his road. There was sweet rice for the elders at his naming, and again when he first ate, and when he was first put in a shirt, and when his hair was first cut.

He was six on the seventh of November, 1861, when the gunboats came into Port Royal Sound. The island calls that day the Gun Shoot. The white people left inside of a day with what they could put in a boat. He was seven the spring after, the first spring anybody at Sandy Field ever planted for himself.

Ma, he said, *I want to go in the valley, under Daddy Titus.*

All right, son. I said a long time ago I would not stand in your road. Go on.

She had Titus to the house and fed him. *Your servant says he wants to seek. I will bring him to you this evening.* That evening she carried the boy to the praise house, with a basket on her head for the elders, and gave him into Titus's hands.

Titus talked to him. *Tite, the valley is hard. When you want it warm you get it cold, and when you want it cold you get it warm. Seekers have a weary time, and you have been raised soft.*

I can do every bit of what you tell me.

All right, then. He gave him five things to carry into the wilderness and look at until he saw them, and only five, because a leader can spoil a seeker with too much: the hair of his head, the hair of his body, his nails, his teeth, his skin. Then he knotted the handkerchief over the boy's forehead, and the house raised the one they raised for seekers.

Jesus call you. Go in de wilderness,
Go in de wilderness, go in de wilderness,
Jesus call you. Go in de wilderness
To wait upon de Lord.

All dem chil'en go in de wilderness
To wait upon de Lord.

— "Go in the Wilderness"

For seven nights Rina and Bacchus stayed by the praise house and fed the elders nothing but rice with milk and molasses. By the fifth night the elders were saying to one another, low, *A man cannot eat sweet rice every night of his life.* On the evening of the seventh the two of them went home, and on the eighth day the boy went out with the basket.

III. Give-It

St. Helena Island and Beaufort · 1862

THE ISLAND HAD HEARD. *THEY SAY THE LITTLE SEEKER IS COMING round today. Let us do something for him.* Women on St. Helena carry everything on the head, on a cloth twisted into a ring for a pad. That morning five hundred of them twisted five hundred new cloths and set five hundred pans of victuals on them, and met him on the shell road. The next day they came into the praise-house yard and did it over. In two days he had a thousand pans and a thousand cloths, and he gave every one of them to the praise house for the old and the sick. The old people said that was the square of handkerchief coming back. They began to call him Give-It.

In July the Government gave up Edisto Island, and a thousand of the Edisto people were brought over and set down at the Village with what they had on their backs. One cold morning in December the boy went through the Village and saw them sitting round lightwood fires in the yards and under the houses.

Why are you all sitting at the fire?

We're cold, bubba.

When it is cold a body ought to wrap up in a blanket. That keeps it off.

You are a lucky child. Maybe you can come by a blanket. Where are we to get one?

Well, he said, *everybody that needs a blanket, come with me.* And he had it called through the Village.

A thousand people got up and followed a child of seven down the road. It did not once come into his head to ask himself where blankets were to be had for so many. He took them along and started. He went from street to street across the island and had five hundred before he came to the ferry, and then he crossed to Beaufort.

A sutler on Bay Street, a Maine man, was sitting in his store door with five hundred army blankets stacked behind him. Somebody going by said, *Mister, there is a little boy coming up the street with a crowd, collecting blankets. You had better put yours away.*

Is he taking them or asking for them?

Asking. As gifts.

Then if I want to give, I will give, and if I don't, I won't. Go on about your business.

But when the man was gone the sutler thought it over. A man is ashamed not to give what is lying in plain sight, and nobody can blame him for what is put away. He had two officers' blankets in the stock that were worth more than all the rest together. He folded them hem to hem and slid them into the middle of the pile.

Then the boy came into the street with the thousand behind him. The sutler looked at him, and something went through his whole body. He thought, For a child like that I would give the meat off my own heart, never mind blankets. He pulled the two out of the pile and laid them at the boy's feet. *Let me have some part in whatever it is you have got hold of.*

So be it, said the boy, and thanked him.

That made five hundred on the island and five hundred in town. He gave the thousand to the Edisto people, and after that he was called Blanket. He had let one fall at his naming and a thousand came back to his hand, and all of them went through it. A lady who taught at the Brick Church wrote home about him, and the answer came that there were people in Boston who would pay his passage if he could be carried North and shown in the churches.

IV. Twenty Leagues

January 1863

HIS MOTHER'S PEOPLE CAME TO THE PRAISE HOUSE TO SEE HIM, and his father's, every day, and sat and talked. On the first of January the paper was read out at Camp Saxton and ten oxen were roasted, and after that it seemed that everybody who passed Sandy Field turned in to look at him. He thought, As long as I stay here they will come and talk to me, and whether they talk or sit quiet, I will never come through. Suppose I got something to carry from the Teacher and went in the wilderness sure enough.

The one the leaders themselves called Teacher was Daddy Quaco, the well-digger. He had dug most of the wells on that end of St. Helena and a good share of the graves. He watched over all the praise houses there, and he had never been known to raise a song. He stood at the wall and based. The boy went and bowed to him and asked for something to carry.

Quaco looked at him awhile. *Every place you lie down, ask who lay there before you. Carry that.*

The boy bowed to Titus. He took his pan and his blanket. If I stop anywhere near, he thought, they will send for me. So he went a long way. In the last week of January the colored regiment went down the coast on three steamers, and one of them put in at Fernandina, on Amelia Island, on the edge of Florida, which the Union had held for most of a year. It is told that he was on that one, sitting on a coil of rope. Nobody had put him there and nobody put him off.

At the head of the wharf road an old man named Robin sat mending a cast net.

Uncle, is there a wilderness anywhere here that a seeker could stay in?

There is.

Show me how to get there.

The old man had taken to him at the first sight. He could have pointed. He laid down the net. *Come on. I will carry you.* They walked south, most of the length of the island. Along the way they passed five or six places that were thick with flowers and fruit, and at each one the boy asked what it was called, and the old man told him. The Orange Old-Field. Sister Pond. The Burnt Mill. Fig Yard. Buzzard Roost. At the last there was live-oak woods with the moss hanging, and behind the woods a hill of sand higher than any ground the boy had ever stood near.

Here is a good place. You stay here. What do they call you? The boy told him. *Come to our street in the morning for your victuals.* Then Robin went back to the south-end settlement, where some forty people were living on a place the owner had left, and called it out along the street. *Wilderness Tite has come to stay at the sand hill. Cook for him.*

So he had been Titus, and Give-It, and Blanket, and now Wilderness. That was four names, and he was not yet eight.

V. Two Sayings

Amelia Island · spring and summer

EARLY THE NEXT MORNING HE WENT INTO THE SETTLEMENT with his pan. When the people put something in it and made their manners, he said, *Be glad. Be free of trouble.* He said nothing else. One man who had given could not make himself go back to his house. They all had to stand and look at him. So he was fed without any hardship.

The whole street got down in front of him. *If you will stay by us these three months, we will build a praise house and keep it three nights in the week, and leave off what we ought to leave off. Promise us.* He saw there was help for them in it, and he promised. After that he came in every morning and only for his victuals. They bowed, and he said the two sayings, *Be glad. Be free of trouble,* and went back to the sand hill. He kept that up the first month and the second. In the third month he came through.

When the cotton was laid by, Daddy Titus went to the Teacher. *I am going down to see my seeker.*

Go, Titus.

Titus started with his own people, and on the way he said to Bristol, who led at the next place, *I am going to see Tite. I will go too,* said Bristol, and brought his. Blind Cupid heard and came with his, and old Kit the barber with his, and so it went until every leader on St. Helena was on the water with a boatload behind him, forty boats.

Robin met them at the landing and bowed.

Uncle, is there a wilderness near here?

There is.

Is there a seeker staying in it?

There is.

What do they call him?

Wilderness Tite.

Then show us the way.

Who are you all?

I have come to see my seeker.

Robin looked them over and knew what they were by how they stood. Joy went all through him. *Wait one minute.* He ran back to the street. *The leaders from Port Royal are here, every one, with their people, to see our boy. Fetch benches and quilts and lamps and oil, and come quick.* The settlement took up what it had and fell in behind the leaders and went out to the sand hill. The boy knew them. He took the pans and bundles of the oldest and did for them what a seeker does for his elders.

While he was still showing them where to lie, it got dark. Titus said to the settlement people, *Go home now. Night has caught you.*

We thought we would hear preaching today. We are not going. We have not heard any yet.

Then light the lightwood and call the meeting. When that was done he said, *Tite, your people say they want to hear. Speak to them.*

The settlement people stood up all together. *Daddy, our seeker doesn't know a thing to say but two sayings. 'Be glad. Be free of trouble.' Let somebody else do the preaching.*

Titus turned to the boy. *Tite. How does a body come to be glad? How does a body get free of trouble? Tell us what is inside those two sayings.*

Yes, Daddy.

He took a palmetto fan in his hand and stood up on a bench, and he spoke until the morning star, the way a storm rains over the whole coast at once and does not slack. He took the body apart piece from piece and the mind after it, and showed them every piece. *That is how one that has come through is glad,* he said. *That is how one that has come through is free of trouble. The rest are not free of being born and dying and what lies between.*

Well done, seeker, said Titus. *You have it right. Now raise it.* And the boy raised it.

At sunup the settlement was in two parties. One was angry. *We never saw anybody so close. He could talk like that, and he ate from our pots three months, and two sayings is all he gave us.* The other was glad. *We are lucky people. We don't know good from bad, and we fed one like him all summer and never knew it, and now we have heard him.*

VI. The Seeker's Pan

The settlement · that morning

DADDY QUACO, ON ST. HELENA, LOOKED OVER THE WORLD early that day as his habit was, and the people of that settlement came into his mind. Some of them are put out with the boy, he thought, and some are pleased. The ones who hold a thing against a child like my son will come to harm by it. I had better go. If I go, they will all be at peace with him.

The settlement had put up a brush arbor and cooked hominy and fish, and set out benches, and sat down to wait. The leaders came in from the sand hill at the hour for eating. They had asked the boy, *Are you coming with us, or after?* and he had said, *When it is my time I will come. You all go ahead.*

Quaco put on his coat at Sandy Field and took up his pan, and between one blink and the next he was standing at the head of the line of leaders as they came into the street. There was one shout. *The Teacher is come!* The whole place was stirred up. They found him a seat, and the leaders, and served them.

Before the meal was done the boy came in from the wilderness. The people got up and filled his pan with all respect. He took as much as he needed and carried it to Quaco and held it out.

Give it here, Tite. Quaco put out his hand and took the pan and showed it to Titus. *Look, Titus. Here is your seeker's pan.*

Titus took it from his hands and gave it back to the boy. *Go and sit where you always sit, and eat.*

When everyone had eaten, the people asked the Teacher to give the thanks. He said: *You are lucky people. On account of one child that came to your doors, you have seen Titus and Bristol and Cupid and Kit and all the rest. I came here my own self on his account and no other. It is your luck. It is your very good luck.*

They thought, We were lucky to lay eyes on a child that teachers and leaders think so much of, and to put food in his pan. The ones who had been angry were pleased, and the pleased were more so, and a good many

came through that day. Then Quaco got up and started back. The settlement walked a piece of the road with him, and turned home.

VII. The Sand Hill

The same day

He walked with the boy at his side, and he asked him what the places were called that they passed, and the boy told him. Buzzard Roost. Fig Yard. The Burnt Mill. Sister Pond. The Orange Old-Field. When they came to where the boy stayed, Quaco climbed the sand hill, and the boy with him. From the top of it you see the ocean.

Tite, when you stand up here and look this way and that, what do you see?

The big water, Daddy.

What comes to you when you look at it?

That in the times I have cried over my troubles, I must have cried more water than that. More than four of that.

Well said, Tite. It is so. Four oceans is the small water. What one body has cried is the big water. Why would anybody go on sleeping?

He had dug for sweet water all his life, and he stood a good while looking at the salt.

Where do you stay?

In the dug place under this hill.

What comes to you while you lie there?

That there is no end to the times I have died and been laid down in this ground.

Well said. It is so. There is no spot of ground where people have not lain down and died. And he told him one. *There was a driver on a place I knew who could not stand to be put in the hands' burying ground among field people. He said to his boy, When I go, lay me in clean ground, where nobody ever was laid. The boy said, Show me any such. He carried him up a little rise between three oaks. Here. Coming down, they met an old man who dug. Where have you two been? They told him. Let us see how clean it is, he said, and he walked them back up. Son, they have buried your father on this rise fourteen thousand times,*

and by that same name. You will not find a hand's breadth anywhere on this earth that has not been somebody's grave.

Then Daddy Quaco, who never raised a song, gave him one. He did not raise it. He said it over, flat, the way he would tell a man how deep he had gone.

I know moon-rise, I know star-rise,
Lay dis body down.
I walk in de moonlight, I walk in de starlight,
To lay dis body down.
I'll walk in de graveyard, I'll walk through de graveyard,
To lay dis body down.
I'll lie in de grave and stretch out my arms;
Lay dis body down.

— "I Know Moon-Rise"

It is so for nearly everyone. The old people did tell of one who died where nobody had died before him. He was so old that the two banks of his river both claimed him, and each meant to have his bones. He had himself rowed out at slack water and died sitting up in the boat in the middle of the stream, so that neither side could say it had him, and both could.

Tite, said Quaco, *when you hear the cats scream in these woods of a night, and the bull alligators, are you afraid?*

No, Daddy. When I hear them, a love for the wilderness comes up in me. And he told over sixty things in it that he loved, the moss and the palmetto and the rest, one after another.

Tite.

Daddy?

I am going. Will you come with me, or turn back?

If my leader wants to carry me, I will go. If he wants me to turn back, I will turn back.

Quaco started down with the leaders. Now it was the boy's own wish to turn back, and Titus knew it. *Tite, turn back if you want to.* The boy

bowed to the Teacher and to all the leaders, and turned back into the woods. Quaco went home to St. Helena.

VIII. The Other Road

Sandy Field praise house · the fall of 1863

They talked about it in the praise house after meeting. *It is a hard thing that child is doing. From the day he was born his people fed the elders sweet rice seven times over. When he went in the valley they fed us seven nights more. The eighth day he went out with the basket, and in two days he had a thousand pans and a thousand cloths. Another day he had a thousand blankets. There were people ready to carry him to Boston. All that came to him here, and he has left the whole of it and gone in the wilderness, and he lives on what is put in his pan.*

Quaco came in. *What are you all sitting here talking about?* They told him.

Yes, he said. *There is one road that goes to getting, and there is another road. A seeker that takes to the wilderness with his eye on what the wilderness will bring him has four bad doors standing open in front of him. The one that knows those two roads apart turns away from what they would heap on him, and goes off by himself, and works, and comes through.*

Then he gave them the song for it, said over in the same flat way.

You may talk of my name as much as you please,
And carry my name abroad,
But I really do believe I'm a child of God
As I walk in de heavenly road.

— "The Heavenly Road"

The next morning he was down a well at Lands End, sending up sand a bucket at a time. They hauled him out at noon, and he asked for the gourd and tasted what was coming in at the bottom.

Background

The verse

> *"One is the road that leads to wealth, another the road that leads to Nirvana;" if the Bhikshu, the disciple of Buddha, has learnt this, he will not yearn for honour, he will strive after separation from the world.*
>
> Dhammapada 75, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a poor Brahmin who has hidden from the elder Sāriputta for shame at having nothing to give at last gives him a whole bowl of porridge and a small cloth, and is reborn into a family of the elder's supporters. As a baby he drops a costly blanket at Sāriputta's feet and is named Tissa after him. At seven he becomes a novice. The town gives him a thousand bowls and cloths in two days, and another day he leads a thousand cold monks out and collects a thousand blankets; he keeps none of it. To get away from his visiting relatives he walks twenty leagues to a forest, where a village feeds him and hears nothing from him but "May you be happy, may you be released from suffering." In three months he is an arahat. When Sāriputta and the great disciples come to see him, the villagers are astonished, and some are offended, to hear him preach all night; the Buddha arrives to reconcile them, questions the boy on a mountain above the ocean, and lets him turn back to the forest. Read the full commentary story.

St. Helena Island, South Carolina

Port Royal, 1861 to 1863

On November 7, 1861, a Union fleet took Port Royal Sound. The planters of the South Carolina sea islands fled, and about ten thousand enslaved people stayed where they were, on land that grew the finest long-staple cotton in the world; the islands remember it as the day of the big gun-shoot. What followed is called the Port Royal Experiment: Northern teachers and superintendents, wages, schools, and the first Black regiment raised from former slaves, the First South Carolina Volunteers

under Thomas Wentworth Higginson, who heard the Emancipation Proclamation read at Camp Saxton on January 1, 1863, and went down the coast by steamer later that month, one transport putting in at Union-held Fernandina on Amelia Island. The superintendents' *Letters from Port Royal* record that a slave household's allowance had been cloth for two suits a year and "a pair of blankets every few years," and that when the Government gave up Edisto Island in 1862 a thousand of its people were quartered at St. Helena Village, where the next winter they still had "nothing." Sandy Field, the south-end settlement, the sand hill and all the people in the story are invented.

Every plantation on St. Helena had its praise house, where the Gullah people held meeting and the ring shout, with the best singers standing at the wall to "base" the shouters. Before anyone could be a member, young or old, they had to seek: to go alone into the woods or the swamp to pray, under an older guide, until they had found what they were hunting for. Higginson wrote that "de lonesome valley" was the islanders' word for it, and that a girl who had entered it "bound a handkerchief by a peculiar knot over her head"; the editors of *Slave Songs of the United States* (1867) quote a boy who could not join the shout yet because he "hain't been on my knees in de swamp." The three songs are given as Higginson took them down from his soldiers at Port Royal in 1862 and 1863 and printed them, in the spelling he used, in the *Atlantic Monthly* in 1867 and in *Army Life in a Black Regiment* (1870).

After the story of the Elder Vanavāsī Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 75). The original. Scripture from three spirituals of the Port Royal islands as written down by Thomas Wentworth Higginson (*Army Life in a Black Regiment*, 1870). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 6

The Wise Man

6.1

Reading Glasses

As an earring of gold, and an ornament of fine gold, so is a wise reprover upon an obedient ear.
— Proverbs 25:12

Honey, the way it was told to me, on Granby Street.

I. The Chief

Granby Street, Norfolk, Virginia · winter 1993

The Garnet Room was on Granby Street, upstairs over a uniform shop, eleven blocks from the water. It had a bar the length of the room, a stage two feet high, a mirror ball, and a show on Friday, Saturday and Sunday nights. It had been there since 1971. For most of those years the state of Virginia had held it unlawful to sell a drink to a homosexual, and a federal judge had struck that rule down only two winters before. Half the men at the bar on any night were Navy and sat with their backs to the door. Everybody knew about the cars that sometimes parked across the street while a man in them wrote down base stickers.

The old man started coming in that January. He was sixty-seven years old, thin, very dark and very straight. He wore a pressed white shirt buttoned to the neck and brown shoes that had been shined that day. He drank one ginger ale, tipped a quarter, and watched the show from the end of the bar as a man watches a ship he is not on.

After a week he asked the bartender whether there was a mop. Within a month he had the place. He came at four, when the door was unlocked for deliveries. He mopped the stage and the stairs and filled the ice wells, and he ran the follow spot from a stool at the back. What he did in the dressing room made him known. He could press. He could put an edge

on a satin lapel that would cut bread, and he could steam six yards of beaded chiffon without losing a bead. He never said where he learned it, and nobody needed him to. A man of that age who pressed like that in Norfolk had been a steward. He had spent his thirty years in the ward-room mess, putting creases in officers' whites, in the branch the Navy had staffed with Black sailors and Filipinos, and almost nobody else, until the middle of the seventies. He had gone in at the bottom of it and come out a chief. The girls called him Chief. His name was Emmett Raines.

He lived in a room on Church Street on what was left of his pension after his sister's nursing home in Portsmouth took its part. He ate at the bar before the doors opened, when the cook made a plate for the staff. The girls were good to him. They brought him sweaters. They let him carry the gowns. They told him things they did not tell each other.

What they would not do was let him in the show. He had asked. He asked the way he did everything, once and correctly, standing up. He had asked Miss Coco Lashley, who was the lead of the cast and did the hiring for Sundays, and she had looked at him over her lashes with real kindness.

Chief, she said. *Baby. You are sixty-seven years old.*

He said he knew how old he was.

You can't walk in a heel. You'd be up there in your first face at an age when most of us have been dead ten years. They'd laugh, and I would have to cut somebody. No, sir. You stay back here with me where it's warm.

He said, *Aye,* and went and filled the ice.

He did not ask again. He went on mopping, and through February he began to lose flesh. The white shirts stood away from his neck. He ate the staff plate and it did him no good. The cook said so.

II. One Good Thing

The Garnet Room · the first week of March

The show director was Miss Geneva Starr. She was fifty-one that year and had run the cast for fourteen. She had been born in

Suffolk, in the peanut country, and raised in a Holiness church where her grandmother was a mother of the congregation, and she had sung there until they put her out at sixteen. She did not lip-synch. She stood at the microphone in a plain dark gown and sang, and sailors who had come upstairs to laugh went down again not speaking. Offstage she said very little. In a house where everybody read everybody, all night, for sport, Miss Geneva had read perhaps six people in fourteen years, and each of them could give you the words.

She had a habit of walking the building at the end of the night, after the last number, when the girls were still at the bar. She said she liked to see what was left when the people went out of it. On a Sunday early in March she came through the dressing room at one in the morning and found Emmett Raines on his knees picking bugle beads out of the floorboards with a table knife.

Chief. What are you doing here?

Squaring away, ma'am.

I don't mean the beads.

He got up. It took him a moment.

Whatever wants doing, he said. *The stage. The ice. I see to the gowns.*

Do they treat you right?

Yes, ma'am. I get my supper. Nobody has said one hard word to me in this house. He set the knife down on the table. *They won't have me in the show. That's all it is. I would like to have been in it once.*

She looked at him for some time, and at the shirt collar. Then she went down the hall and brought the whole cast back with her, seven girls with their drinks, half out of their faces. She stood them in the dressing room in front of him.

I want to ask you all something, she said. *Does anybody in this room remember one good thing this man ever did? I don't mean the mopping. I mean a thing he did for one of you.*

Nobody spoke. They looked at each other. He had done every one of them a hundred small services since January, and not one of them could have named one.

Then Coco Lashley put her glass down.

I do, she said. She said it slowly, looking at him as if he had just walked in. *Lord. I do, Mother. It was Naples. Nineteen seventy-eight.*

She had been Seaman Apprentice Darnell Lashley then, nineteen years old, on a ship tied up at Naples, and she had come back aboard eleven hours late from a bar off the Via Roma that she did not care to describe to the executive officer. At captain's mast they gave her three days in the brig on bread and water. The Navy could still do that to a seaman then. It was bread, as much as you wanted, and water, and a steel bunk. On the second night she was sick with something besides hunger. She had understood by then what the ship knew about her and what the rest of her enlistment was going to be.

And the hatch opens, she said, *and it's not the master-at-arms. It's the old chief from the wardroom mess. I never spoke to him in my life. Stewards didn't come down there. He's got a soup ladle in his hand with a saucer under it, and it's navy beans, still hot. He says, This is off my own plate, son, so it's nobody's business. Eat it and give me back my ladle. And he stood there with his back to the hatch till I did.*

She had been put out of the Navy three years later, for the usual reason. She had not seen him again. She had looked at him across a dressing room every night for two months and seen an old man with a mop.

That was you, she said.

I recollect a ladle, Emmett said. *I didn't know it was you. You've filled out.*

Coco, Miss Geneva said. *Do you think it's right to leave a man standing outside who did that?*

No, Mother.

Well, then.

I'll take him, Coco said. *He's mine. I'll bring him out myself.*

III. The Wheel Book

March and April

SHE GAVE HIM THE LAST PLACE AT THE DRESSING TABLE, THE short end by the mop sink, where the bulb over the mirror flickered. She gave him the first number on Sundays. That was the spot nobody wanted,

AT NINE O'CLOCK, WHEN THE ROOM WAS A THIRD FULL AND still sober. She gave him a name. He was to be Miss Emmaline Raines, since a lady of that age would not be anything shorter. Then she started on him.

Coco Lashley was the best reader in Tidewater. Her people were Lashleys out of Harlem. A great-uncle of hers had kept the door of a building on Edgecombe Avenue for forty years, and it was said in the family that he never forgot a face or what he owed it. She had his eye. She could take a queen apart from the wig lace to the shoe in one breath and be right about every piece. She had read grown performers off that stage and out of the business.

She read Emmett Raines every day for seven weeks.

Chief, you walk like you are carrying a tray. Put the tray down. Nobody is waiting on their coffee.

Your mouth is half a beat behind the record. The lady is singing, and you are reading her lips.

That is not a cheekbone. That is a stripe.

The wig is wearing you. Go back and put it on like you paid for it.

Don't thank them when they clap. Don't you bow. You have been bowing for thirty years. Stand there and take it like it's owed.

Stop. Go back. Again.

She said things to him that she would not have said to a girl of twenty, because a girl of twenty would have gone home. The cast heard it through the wall and winced.

He could not see his own face in the glass without his spectacles. They were drugstore readers, a dollar ninety-eight, with brown frames. He could not paint around them and could not go on in them. So he painted in them and took them off, and Coco told him what he had done wrong, and he put them on again to look. He kept a green memorandum book in his shirt pocket, the kind every chief in the Navy carries and calls his wheel book. Each time she finished he said, *Aye,* took out the book and the readers, and wrote it down. He wrote down the tray, and the stripe, and half a beat behind. He never once explained himself. He did not sulk or cut his eyes at her. He never told her what he had been in the Navy

when she was in diapers, though it was true and she knew it. The next day the thing she had named would be gone, and she would find another.

He put some weight back on. The cook noticed that first.

IV. Sunday

The Garnet Room · the last Sunday in April

NOBODY COULD SAY AFTERWARD WHICH SUNDAY IT HAD become a different matter. It may only have been that the room was fuller. A ship had come in.

He went on at nine in a gray gown that Coco had cut down for him, long in the sleeve and high at the neck. He wore a small gray wig and one strand of glass pearls. The number was an old Dinah Washington record, a slow one. He walked to the center, and he was not carrying anything. He did not work the room or beg it. He stood and let the song come through him. He was an old woman who had seen what the song said and was past minding who knew. His mouth was on every word. Somewhere in the second verse the bar went quiet, and the bartender stopped the blender with his hand.

The girls in the wings said that what struck them was that he did not want anything from the house. Every one of them wanted something out there. They wanted the dollars, or the noise, or one face at one table. He stood in the light and wanted nothing. When it was over he did not bow. The room got to its feet anyway, sailors and all, and stayed there.

Miss Geneva had watched from the back, beside the doorman, a man called Tiny who filled the stair and had never been seen to hurry. She came to the dressing room afterward. Emmett had the readers on and was looking in the glass to see what he had got wrong.

Coco, she said. *This daughter of yours. Is she easy to tell?*

Mother, I have read that man every way I know how, and a few I made up. He says aye and writes it in his little book. Whatever I name, he fixes. He has never once given me a look.

If you could get them like that, how many would you take?

Every one they'd send me, Coco said. *I'd take a busload.*

V. The White Mule

The dressing room · later that night

THE CAST SAT LATE. THEY WERE PLEASED WITH HIM AND SOMEwhat ashamed. The talk came around, as it will, to Coco, who had carried one ladle of beans in her head for fifteen years and paid it back like that. One of them said that most people wouldn't remember their own mother that long. Another said the old man had been lucky in his teacher. The first one said the teacher had been lucky too, because Coco's mouth would have killed anybody else.

Miss Geneva was unpinning her hair.

That's nothing new for her, she said. *She has always been that kind.* Then she told them a story, which she almost never did. It was her grandfather's, who had cut timber in the Dismal Swamp.

There was a gang of men, he said, that went into the swamp every fall to get out juniper. They cut the logs and hewed them square on the spot. They marked every piece with a number and floated the frames down the canal to Suffolk, to be put up as houses. One fall an old mule came limping out of the reeds on three legs and lay down by their fire. She belonged to nobody. She had a splinter of cypress knee through the frog of her hoof and the leg was swollen to the shoulder. The men cut around the splinter with a chisel. They tied a line to it and drew it out, and washed the place with warm water, and kept her by the fire till it closed.

When she could walk, that mule went to work for them. Nobody had put a hand on her. She snaked logs. She stood where a man needed something to stand against. They said she would carry an adze to you in her teeth. Each man gave her a piece of his own corn bread at noon, and with a gang that size she lived well.

After some years she got slow. She went off into the reeds one morning and came back that evening with a colt behind her. He was white all over and had never worn a collar. She stood him in front of the men. She looked at them and she looked at him, and then she went back into the swamp, and they did not see her again. The colt worked for them as his

mother had. He let the men's children ride him into the canal on Sundays.

Word of a white mule gets around. The man who owned the mill at Suffolk came out in a buggy to have him, and the gang said, *Take him, Captain, he's yours.* The mule would not move. The mill man was no fool. He counted out silver dollars and laid one down at each hoof. The mule stood still. He laid down a bolt of cloth for every wife in the camp, and the mule stood. So he laid down shoes for the children who had ridden him. Then the mule looked one time at all of them, the men and the wives and the children, and walked to the buggy.

There's more to it, Miss Geneva said. *Years after, that mule saved the mill for the man's baby son, when the father was dead and some people from Richmond came to take it. That's another night.* She put the last pin in the dish. *My grandfather said there are people who are that old mule. You do them one turn, and they will send you the best thing they have. And he said some people are the colt. He will not walk off from where he's been fed till everybody there is paid.*

She did not say which was which. Coco was looking at the floor.

VI. The Mirror

The same night

OVER THE LONG MIRROR IN THAT DRESSING ROOM THERE WAS A piece of shirt cardboard, gone brown, with four lines lettered on it in green ink. Miss Dorian had put it up, who ran the cast before Geneva. She had been a high school English teacher in Newport News until 1962, when they found out about her. She died in 1989 in the hospital on Colley Avenue, and four of the girls who had sat with her were dead since. Nobody had taken the card down, and nobody new had ever been told to read it.

Miss Geneva reached up and touched the corner of it.

> *Have you learn'd lessons only of those who admired you, and were tender with you, and stood aside for you?*
> *Have you not learn'd great lessons from those who reject you, and brace themselves against you? or who treat you with contempt, or dispute the passage with you?*
>
> *— Walt Whitman, "Stronger Lessons," Leaves of Grass*

Dorian had her poet, she said. *My grandmother had it shorter.* She stood with her hand on the back of Emmett's chair and said it as she had learned it, standing up in the Holiness church in Suffolk at seven years old.

> *As an earring of gold, and an ornament of fine gold, so is a wise reprover upon an obedient ear.*
>
> *— Proverbs 25:12*

Children, listen. When somebody tells you your slip is showing, she has put money in your hand. She didn't have to. It would have been easier for her to let you walk out there. When you find one who will look at you that hard and say what she sees, don't you get your back up. Stay by her. You'll come out better for it. I never knew anybody who came out worse.

She looked down the table at the seven of them, and at the old man at the short end.

He knew that when he came in the door. He was the only one in this house who did.

Then she said good night and went to walk the building.

The girls drifted out. The mirror ball had been left turning in the empty room, and through the dressing-room door its spots of light went slowly across the ceiling. Emmett sat at the short end of the table and took the gray wig off and set it on its block.

Coco had her coat on. She stopped behind him.

You came off stage left, she said. *In this house we exit right. And you had lipstick on your tooth the whole second verse.*

Aye, he said.

He put on the reading glasses and took the green book out of his shirt pocket and wrote it down.

Background

The verse

> *If you see an intelligent man who tells you where true treasures are to be found, who shows what is to be avoided, and administers reproofs, follow that wise man; it will be better, not worse, for those who follow him.*
>
> Dhammapada 76, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Rādha is a poor old brahmin of Sāvatthī who goes to live at the monastery, cutting grass, sweeping cells and fetching water. The monks treat him kindly but will not ordain him, and he grows thin. The Buddha, walking the grounds one evening, asks him what he is doing there, then calls the monks together and asks whether anyone remembers a good deed of his. Sāriputta remembers that in Rājagaha the man once gave him a ladleful of his own food, and agrees to ordain him. Rādha is seated in the outermost row. Sāriputta takes him everywhere and corrects him constantly, and Rādha follows every instruction without resentment and soon becomes an arahat. Asked how many such pupils he would accept, Sāriputta says as many as he could get. When the monks praise Sāriputta's gratitude, the Buddha tells the birth story of the elephant whose foot was healed by a camp of carpenters, who worked for them and then gave them his white son; the young elephant would not leave with the king until the carpenters, their wives and their children had all been paid. The Buddha then says that one who points out faults should be regarded as one who shows where treasure is buried. Read the full commentary story.

Norfolk, Virginia

Norfolk, 1993

Norfolk is home to the largest naval base in the world, and its gay bars have always been full of sailors who could be discharged for being seen there. Until a federal court ruled in a 1991 case, Virginia's liquor regulations forbade licensed bars to serve homosexuals or become their meeting places. In 1993 the country argued over

whether gay people could serve at all; the compromise known as "Don't Ask, Don't Tell" was signed into law that November. In June 1991 about eighty people had marched from Old Dominion University to the gates of the base. The city's drag shows go back at least to the Cue Club of the 1970s. In drag houses an experienced performer, a drag mother, names and trains a newcomer; to "read" someone is to tell her faults to her face, exactly and with wit, and it is counted an art. The Garnet Room and its cast are invented.

Until the steward and commissaryman ratings were merged on January 1, 1975, the men who cooked for, served and kept the quarters of Navy officers belonged to a branch that was largely segregated, filled by Black and Filipino sailors. Confinement on bread and water for up to three days was a lawful punishment for junior sailors aboard ship until January 1, 2019. Whitman's two lines were first printed in 1860 and stand among the last poems of *Leaves of Grass*. Miss Geneva's swamp tale follows the Alīnacitta Jātaka, with a mule where the old story has an elephant.

After the story of the Elder Rādha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 76). The original. Scripture from Walt Whitman, *Leaves of Grass*, and the King James Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.2

Lilac Slips

I have the goats. And I have a few sheep among my goats, but they are very ragged.
— Narrative of Sojourner Truth

This is how the old people told it, in Calvin Township.

I. The Mill Branch

Calvin Township, Cass County, Michigan · spring 1858

Mother Ruth Ann Hollins had come out from Northampton County, North Carolina, in a covered wagon in the fall of 1844, with her husband and four grown children and her free papers sewn into the lining of her bonnet, and by 1858 she had outlived the husband and two of the children and was the nearest thing to a bishop the colored Methodists of Calvin Township had. She was not ordained to anything. The Discipline did not ordain women. She was a class leader, which the Discipline allowed, and she prayed and testified and exhorted whether the Discipline allowed it or not, and she had been doing all three every Sunday and Wednesday for fourteen years in a log meeting-house on the edge of a tamarack swamp. Most of the families round about had come out the same road, from Virginia and the Carolinas, free people of color with a little Indian in most of them and a lot of Indian in some. The fugitives came later, at night, by way of the Quaker farms, and some of them stayed. She did not ask them anything when they came to meeting. She asked them their names and said them back, and that was all.

Two men did most of her preaching for her, and the township called them her right hand and her left. Silas Porter was a cooper, thin and

quiet, who could take a hard place in Paul and lay it open like a stave. Mose Gallion was a blacksmith from Halifax County, as big as his anvil, and when Mose prayed at a camp meeting, men who had come to laugh went down in the straw like steers that have been hit between the eyes and lay there an hour and got up weeping. People said he could see the inside of a man the way he saw the color of iron in the fire. Nobody doubted it.

Each of them had a young man he was bringing along. Silas had Asa Freeland, who had a voice like a bell and could line out a hymn so that the whole swamp sang it back. Mose had Prentiss Booker, whom everybody called Bass, who was handsome and quick and could make any congregation laugh and then cry inside of a quarter hour. Two years before, when the families out at the Rocky Fork, eight miles north where Kimmel's sawmill was, asked for a class of their own so they would not have to walk in every Sunday, Mother Ruth Ann sent Asa and Bass to lead it.

It went well for a season. Then it went another way.

The first thing anybody noticed was the lilacs. Asa and Bass planted a row of them all along the front of the Rocky Fork schoolhouse where the class met, and rose bushes at the corners, and flowering crab apples down the lane, and by the second spring the schoolhouse looked like a rich man's front yard. Then they started cutting slips. They rooted lilac slips in wet moss and carried them round to the houses where there were daughters, and roses in May, and crab-apple blossom in a pail, and the mothers set the table for them, and the fathers gave them a ham or a sack of meal or a dollar for the preaching, and they went home heavy. They held play-parties in the schoolhouse on Saturday nights, with the benches pushed to the walls and the girls going round in Weevily Wheat and Skip to My Lou, and people said that once or twice the play-party had had a fiddle in it, which made it a dance, and the Discipline was plain about dancing. There was card playing out behind the sawmill with the mill hands, for money. There was talk about Bass and a girl at the Wilkins place, and the girl's father had stopped speaking to anybody. Old Widow Tate, who had nothing, had given them her last two dollars for a

love offering because they told her it would be credited to her in glory, and now she had nothing and two dollars less.

The steady ones at the Rocky Fork, the old people who had come to be Methodists and not to play Skip to My Lou, stopped going to the schoolhouse. They walked the eight miles in to the log meetinghouse on Sundays instead, and back again in the dark. When the walk got too hard for them, some of them stopped going anywhere.

II. The Book

Mother Ruth Ann's kitchen · May

It was the old ones who came to her finally, three of them, Brother and Sister Anthony and old Lige Day, who had walked in from the Rocky Fork in the rain. They did not want to make trouble for anybody. They sat at her table with their hats on their knees and told it, and she listened, and when they were done she thanked them and gave them supper and sent her grandson to hitch the wagon and drive them home.

Then she sent for Silas Porter and Mose Gallion.

They came in from their work, the cooper with shavings in his hair and the blacksmith with his apron still on. They had heard most of it already. They knew why they had been sent for, and they did not like it, because the two young men were theirs.

You will go out to the Rocky Fork, she said, *you two, Saturday week, and stay the Sunday. Talk to them. Teach them. Any that will hear you, keep them, and keep teaching them. Any that won't hear you, put them out of the class. I'll stand behind you at the quarterly meeting.*

Mose rubbed his face. *Bass will hate me for it.*

He will, she said. *The man that tells a fool the truth gets hated by the fool. That's how it is. The ones with any sense in them will love you for it, maybe not the same day.*

She had a book on the shelf by the clock, a thin one, bound in paper, and she sent her grandson for it. She had bought it in the fall from the woman who made it, at a meeting in Battle Creek, where that woman had

lately come to live: a tall Black woman about Mother Ruth Ann's own age, who had been a slave in New York and named herself Sojourner Truth and went about the country speaking, and sold the book of her life at the end of every meeting to keep herself. Mother Ruth Ann could not read much. Her grandson could. She had him find the place, near the middle, about a camp meeting in Massachusetts years before where a hundred wild young men came to break it up with clubs and set the tents on fire, and the woman went out alone and stood on a little rise in the moonlight and sang, and they came and stood around her with their sticks.

The boy read it out slowly by the lamp. Silas and Mose listened with their elbows on the table.

> *She looked about her, and with her usual discrimination, said inwardly —'Here must be many young men in all this assemblage, bearing within them hearts susceptible of good impressions. I will speak to them.'*
>
> *'Well, there are two congregations on this ground. It is written that there shall be a separation, and the sheep shall be separated from the goats. The other preachers have the sheep, I have the goats. And I have a few sheep among my goats, but they are very ragged.'*
>
> *— Narrative of Sojourner Truth*

Mose Gallion laughed in spite of himself, the way the young men in the book had laughed, and then put his head down on his arms.

Look for the ones with the hearts in them, Mother Ruth Ann said. *Speak to them. And don't you be afraid of the goats.*

III. The Schoolhouse

The Rocky Fork · the last Saturday in May

THE LILACS WERE IN FULL BLOOM WHEN THEY DROVE UP, THE whole front of the schoolhouse purple and white, and the smell of them came down the lane to meet the wagon. There was a play-party starting inside. They could hear it from the road, the clapping and somebody calling the figures, and Bass Booker's laugh over all of it.

Mose Gallion got down and went and stood in the schoolhouse door. He did not say anything. He did not need to. He filled it from the sill to the lintel, and the clapping stopped, and the girls stopped going round, and the boys from the mill who had been leaning on the walls stood up off them. Silas Porter came in past him and set a chair in the middle of the floor where the play had been, and sat down on it, and took out his Testament, and waited until the room was quiet. Then he talked to them.

He talked until after dark, the way he would have talked to a barrel that was leaking, a stave at a time. He did not shout. He named the widow's two dollars, and the Wilkins girl, and the cards behind the mill, and he named them in front of the mothers who had set the tables and the fathers who had paid for the preaching, so that it went round the room like a draft. Then he read them a long piece out of the second chapter of James, about the man with the gold ring and the poor man in vile raiment, and asked them which one Widow Tate was. Mose stood in the door the whole time with his arms folded and his eyes going from one face to another, and people said afterward that every one of them felt him looking inside, and found out what it was like to be a piece of iron in the fire.

It did not go one way. It went three.

Asa Freeland broke first. He had been standing by the stove with his hymnbook in his hand, and somewhere in the middle of James he sat down on a bench and put his face in his hands. At the end he got up and went out in the dark, and came back with the widow's two dollars and four more of his own and put them in Silas Porter's hand, and asked if he might go back to carrying Silas's tools a while, and lead the singing and nothing else. Some of the young people went with him, the ones with the hearts in them. A Wilkins boy cried. Two of the girls went home with their mothers and came to class the next morning with their heads tied up plain.

Some of the others said nothing at all, got their hats, and went out. A few of them were never seen in a Methodist class again. They went back to the mill and the plow and their own business and lived their lives, and married, and some of them got rich in a small way, and nobody could say

it was the worst thing that ever happened to them. In the language of the Discipline, a preacher who quits the traveling work and goes home to his farm is said to have *located*. The township took up the word for anybody who left that night. *He located,* they said, and it was not unkind.

Bass Booker did neither. He stood up in front of the room and told Silas Porter what he thought of an old cooper who had never been out of the township coming to tell him how to preach, and told Mose Gallion what he thought of a big ignorant smith standing in a door like a hog in a gate, and he laughed, and a few laughed with him, and he walked out past Mose into the lilacs. At the quarterly meeting in June his name was read out and he was suspended from the Society, and Mother Ruth Ann stood up in the back of the log meetinghouse when it was read, as she had said she would, so that everyone could see whose doing it was. Bass told it all over the county that summer that Mose Gallion was a jealous old fool, and he hated Mose until the day Mose died, and some say after.

He was the only one who took anything with him when he went. On his way out that night, in the dark, he broke off an armful of lilac from the bushes he had planted, and walked off down the mill road with it over his shoulder, and the smell went along with him a long way after you could not see him anymore.

Silas Porter rooted a slip from the same bushes the next spring, in wet moss, the way Asa had shown him, and carried it out to Widow Tate's, and set it by her door.

Background

The verse

> *Let him admonish, let him teach, let him forbid what is improper!—he will be beloved of the good, by the bad he will be hated.*
>
> Dhammapada 77, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two monks who are pupils of the Buddha's chief disciples settle with their followers at Kīṭāgiri and run the place into disrepute: they plant flowering trees and give flowers to lay families to win their favor, live off what the families give, and behave so badly that well-conducted monks can no longer stay there. The

Buddha sends Sāriputta and Moggallāna, telling them to expel those who will not obey and to admonish and teach those who will, since the one who admonishes is hated by fools and loved by the wise, and speaks the verse. The two elders go. Some of the monks accept correction, some return to lay life, and some are formally suspended. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta and Moggallāna.

Calvin Township, Cass County, Michigan

Cass County, Michigan, 1858

From 1829 Quakers from Ohio and Indiana and free Black families settled the southwestern Michigan county of Cass, above all Calvin Township, where by 1850 a quarter of the people were African American, many of them families of mixed Native ancestry as well. The county was a station on the Underground Railroad, and freedom seekers who came through on their way to Canada sometimes stayed. In August 1847 Kentucky slaveholders raided the Quaker farms and seized nine people; a crowd of white and Black neighbors stopped them at a mill in Vandalia, and a local court set the captives free along with dozens of others (the Kentucky raid). The Methodist society, its people and the Rocky Fork are invented.

Sojourner Truth, born into slavery in Ulster County, New York, dictated her life to Olive Gilbert, and the *Narrative of Sojourner Truth* was printed in 1850; she sold it at her meetings to support herself. Its account of an 1844 camp meeting near Northampton, Massachusetts, where she faced down a mob of young men by singing, is the passage read in Mother Ruth Ann's kitchen. In September 1857 Truth moved to Michigan, near Battle Creek, some forty-five miles from Calvin, and made Michigan her home for the rest of her life.

After the story of the followers of Assaji and Punabbasu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 77). The original. The verse from the *Narrative of Sojourner Truth* (1850). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

6.3

Fourth Day

For from the good thou shalt learn good...
— Theognis 35

This I had by relation, at Enderby on the Merrimack.

I. The Wash-Way

Fen Enderby, Lincolnshire · October 1634

Mr. Josias Markby was the squire's second son, and for nineteen years he had held the family living of Fen Enderby, in the parts of Holland. It was a fat one. It was worth a hundred and thirty pounds a year in tithe wool and tithe geese and the rent of the glebe marsh, and it came with a brick parsonage and an orchard walled against the east wind. He had a wife and a daughter in that house who loved him. John Chaney was his man. The two of them had been born in the one week in the one parish, the squire's boy in the hall and the groom's boy over the stable, and Chaney had saddled for him since they were both small.

In the autumn of 1634 the Archbishop's visitors came through the fens asking which ministers wore the surplice, and which had read the King's book of Sunday sports from the pulpit as they were ordered. Mr. Markby had done neither. He was cited, and did not go. In the second week of October a neighbor sent a boy over the dyke at dusk to say that a pursuivant of the High Commission was lying at an inn in Boston with a warrant in his coat.

He left that night and told nobody in the house. He came out to the stable in his gown, with a candle, and found Chaney awake already, because Chaney slept with one ear on the horses. *The grey, John. And the cob for you.* They rode south along the sea bank with the wind behind them,

twenty-odd miles in the dark, and came at first light to the wash-way below Sutton, where the river runs out over the sands into the great bay, and where at dead ebb a man who has a guide may walk two miles across the bottom of the sea and come up in Norfolk.

The guide was there with his pole. The tide was out. Mr. Markby got down. He took off his gown and folded it, and took the seal ring from his finger and the keys of the church from his belt and laid them in the gown, and handed the bundle up to Chaney, and the grey's rein after it.

Carry these to Mistress Markby. Tell her I am gone over, and will send.

I'll come with you.

You will go back, John.

Chaney sat the cob and watched him walk out behind the guide, a man in a doublet with a stick, getting smaller on the wet sand, until either the light was too poor or he was too far. Then he turned the two horses and rode back into the wind the way he had come, and told the mistress standing in her kitchen. The grey would not feed after that week. It was dead before Martinmas.

Mr. Markby lay hid in London through the winter and took ship in the spring. His wife and the girl followed him in the summer of 1635, and Chaney came with them, with the gown in his own chest.

For the rest of his life, whenever the talk came anywhere near it, Chaney said the same thing. *I rode with him that night. There was him and me and the horses. I have never looked to another man since, and I never will.*

II. The Word by Itself

Enderby on the Merrimack · 1638 to 1648

They called the plantation Enderby, since most of them had come out of the fens together, and there was salt marsh enough at the river's mouth to make them feel they had not come so very far. Thirty-odd families gathered a church there, with Mr. Markby for its pastor, and built a meetinghouse of sawn boards with a thatched roof and no bell. Chaney beat the drum for meeting. He beat the first drum at eight

AND THE SECOND AT NINE, EVERY LORD'S DAY AND EVERY LECture day, and it was understood in the town that nobody else would be asked.

On the fourth day of each week Mr. Markby read Greek in his study with such boys of the town as were meant for the College at Cambridge and the ministry after it. He had one grammar and a thick little book of the lesser Greek poets, printed at the other Cambridge the year after he went over the sands and sent out to him by a friend. Its first leaf had carried a dedication to the Archbishop. He had cut that out and lit the fire with it. The boys stood in a row and told over their paradigms. *Tupto, I strike. Tupteis, thou strikest. Tuptei, he striketh.* Chaney carried in the wood and then sat down beside it on the floor inside the door, mending harness, since on a weekday morning the study had the only fire in the house, and nobody thought anything of it. He had no letters, English or any other.

First the etymologie, Mr. Markby told every new boy, *which is the word by itself, in all its changes. Then the syntax, which is the word in company. A good many men get the first and die without the second.* Once, to make them laugh, he told them that Goodman Chaney's drum was Greek too, *tympanon*, the thing struck, and came out of the same *tupto* they were yawning over.

In 1638 the church called a second minister to be its Teacher. This was Mr. Thomas Sarson, lately of Emmanuel College, who was thirty years old and had the Hebrew as well as the Greek. For Ruling Elder it chose William Moulton, a cooper, a large, slow, careful man who had come over in 1637 and whom the whole town trusted with its quarrels. Mr. Markby leaned on the two of them more every year. He was past sixty. When he was asked a hard thing he had begun to say, *Put it to Mr. Sarson,* or, *What does the Elder think?*

Chaney could not bear it.

He said so at the well and at the mill and on the meetinghouse step with the drum still on his shoulder. *Where were they the night he went over the sands? One was at his book and the other at his barrels. I was there, I and the horses. Now it is* I am the Teacher, *and* I am the Ruling Elder, *and a man*

must go through the pair of them like two gates to come at his own master. He mocked the way Mr. Sarson held up one finger when he preached. He said in the hearing of children that the Elder counted the hoops on every word before he let it out.

It was carried to Mr. Markby, who sent for him. *John, they are good men, and they have done you no wrong. Leave it.* Chaney stood and looked at the floor and said nothing for about as long as it takes to say the Lord's Prayer. Then he went out to the woodpile, and the boy who was splitting there heard the whole of it over again.

He was sent for a second time, and it went the same way.

The third time Mr. Markby did not see him alone. It was a fourth day. The boys were there, Mr. Sarson and the Elder had come in about a boundary, and Chaney was on the floor by the wood with a breast-strap across his knees. The old man had the book of poets open at Theognis of Megara, whom the boys found easy. He turned in his chair.

John Chaney. In these two you have friends who are good men, the best you are like to meet with on this side of the grave. Make friends of such men, and follow such, and no others. Then he put it into English for him off the page, slowly, as he did for the boys.

> *...consort not with bad men, but ever cleave to the good: with them eat and drink, sit with them, and please them, of whom there is a large force. For from the good thou shalt learn good, but with the bad if thou shouldst mix, thou wilt lose even the mind thou hast.*
>
> *— Theognis 31–36*

Two of the boys who stood in the row that morning said in later life that they had got more good of those six lines than of all the rest of their Greek. Chaney got up, made his duty to the three of them, and carried out the ash bucket. Before noon he was heard at the well on the subject of gates.

When the brethren came to complain of it again, Mr. Markby heard them through. *You will not teach John Chaney while I am alive,* he said. *After I am dead you will.*

III. The Second Drum

Enderby · January to June 1649

He took to his bed at the turn of the year, in a hard frost. Stephen Anderby, a young man of the town who had been two years at the College and come home when his father died, sat up with him at night. Near the end Anderby asked him what the church was to do about Goodman Chaney.

Lay the heaviest thing on him.

Cast him out, sir?

No. Keep him in. Let him say whatever he will. Let no one answer him, nor reprove him, nor teach him, nor bid him good day, until he is another man. Tell Mr. Sarson I ask it.

He died on the eleventh of January. They kept a fire burning on the ground a day and a night before it could be opened. Chaney walked behind the bier at the widow's elbow, as near as a man could get.

On the next Lord's day, when the afternoon exercise was over, Mr. Sarson stayed the church. He had Anderby stand and say what he had been told, in the dead man's words. Then he took up his copy of the Platform of discipline that the Synod at Cambridge had finished the summer before, and read from its chapter of censures the place that came nearest.

> *While the offender remains excommunicate, the church is to refrain from all member-like communion with him in spiritual things, and also from all familiar communion with him in civil things, further than the necessity of natural, or domestical, or civil relations do require; and are therefore to forbear to eat and drink with him, that he may be ashamed.*
>
> *— Cambridge Platform XIV.5*

Our pastor asked less than this, and more, Mr. Sarson said. *John Chaney is not put out. He may sit where he sits. But from this hour no brother or sister of this church is to answer him.* He called for hands, and the hands went up.

Chaney had stood at his own name. He stood a moment longer with his mouth working. Then his knees went, and he came down his whole

length in the alley between the benches and lay there. When he could speak he spoke to the Elder, who was nearest. *Do not undo me, sir. Three times he let me go free. Three times.* The Elder looked at Mr. Sarson. Neither of them answered him, and that was the beginning of it.

He beat the first drum and the second drum the next Lord's day as he always had, and the town came past him into the meetinghouse. For some weeks he went on talking at the well and the mill, of the two gates at first and then of other things, the frost, a lame ox, the price of nails, and the women drew their water and went home. Mistress Markby, whose servant he still was, set his meat on a bench in the lean-to and ate her own at the table. By March he had left off talking. He cut the wood for three houses and swept the meetinghouse and kept the drumheads from the damp, and he was on the step with the sticks in his hands at eight and again at nine.

The Greek went on, on fourth days, in the same room, under Mr. Sarson now. Nobody had told Chaney he was not to carry in the wood and sit by it, and he did.

On a fourth day in June the boys were in the passive voice, where boys always stuck. *Tuptomai, I am struck. Tuptē, thou art struck.* The Hale boy stopped there and stood with his mouth open. Mr. Sarson waited.

Tuptetai, said Chaney from the floor.

Nobody turned round. He went on in the same low voice, with his eyes on the strap in his lap, the way a man tells over his own cattle at the gate. *Tuptometha. Tuptesthe. Tuptontai.* Then he said, in English, to no one, *Fifteen year I sat by it and thought it was for boys.*

That is right, John, said Mr. Sarson, before he had thought.

The boys looked at Mr. Sarson, and Mr. Sarson looked at the book. He did not take it back. *Go on from there, Hale,* he said, and the boy went on.

The church book of Enderby shows no vote that took the censure off. On the next Lord's day the Elder, going in at the second drum, said *Good morrow, John,* and those who came in behind him said it too. After the sermon Chaney was asked, as the order was, whether he had anything to say to the church. He stood up. *They were the best men I ever met with, and I would not see it.* Then he sat down again.

On the fourth day following there was a stool by the wood inside the study door. Nobody owned to having set it there. He sat on it.

Background

The verse

> *Do not have evil-doers for friends, do not have low people for friends: have virtuous people for friends, have for friends the best of men.*
>
> Dhammapada 78, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Channa is the groom who rode out with Prince Siddhattha on the night he left the palace, and who carried the horse and the ornaments home from the river. Later, as a monk, he could not forgive the two chief disciples, Sāriputta and Moggallāna, for standing nearer the Buddha than he did, and he abused them. Three times he was admonished; each time he was silent a moment and then went on as before. The Buddha said that Channa could not be taught while he lived, and on his deathbed told Ānanda to lay on him the "supreme penalty": he might say what he liked, and no monk was to speak to him, exhort him or correct him. When the sentence was read Channa fell down and begged not to be ruined. He went off, did his work, and became an arahat, at which the penalty lapsed of itself. Read the full commentary story, or about Channa.

Enderby (fictional), Merrimack River, Massachusetts Bay

Massachusetts Bay, 1634 to 1649

William Laud became Archbishop of Canterbury in 1633. That October the King's Declaration of Sports was reissued, to be read from every pulpit, and from 1634 Laud's vicar-general carried a visitation through the province. Ministers who would not conform were cited before the Court of High Commission, whose warrants were served by officers called pursuivants, and a good many slipped away at night and

joined the migration to New England, which carried some twenty thousand people over between 1620 and 1640. The sands of the Wash could be crossed on foot at low water with a guide; William Camden wrote that when the tide was out "a man may pass over it as on dry land, but yet not without danger." Fen Enderby, Enderby on the Merrimack and everyone in them are invented.

A New England church of the first generation had, where it could afford them, a pastor and a teacher, and a lay ruling elder beside them, and a town without a bell was called to meeting by a drum. The synod that met at Cambridge from 1646 to 1648 wrote the churches' practice down as the Cambridge Platform; its fourteenth chapter, on censures, is quoted here from the Boston edition of 1855. The College at Cambridge was founded in 1636 so as not, in the words of *New England's First Fruits* (1643), to leave "an illiterate ministry to the churches," and the timetable printed in that pamphlet gives the fourth day of the week to Greek, with "Etymologie and Syntax" for the first-year men. Etymology then meant the forms of the single word. The verb the boys decline, *typtō*, "I strike," was the stock paradigm of the old grammars, and the Greek word for a drum does come from it. The book of poets is Ralph Winterton's *Poetae minores Graeci* (Cambridge, 1635), dedicated to Laud, which includes the maxims of Theognis. The English is the prose version of the Rev. J. Banks (1856).

After the story of the Elder Channa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 78). The original. Scripture from Theognis, tr. J. Banks (1856), and the Cambridge Platform (1648). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.4

The Placemat

And thou shalt cause them to drink of the full stream of thy delights.
— Psalm 35:9 (Septuagint)

Έτσι το άκουσα, on Route 46.

I. The King of Route 46

Clifton, New Jersey · summer 2011

Vasilis Kappas owned five diners on Route 46 and in the towns around it, and everyone from Paterson to Parsippany called him the King, which was also what his name meant, so he could not pretend he minded.

There was the Olympia, with the columns. There was the Golden Star, and the Galaxy, which had a revolving cake case with eleven kinds of cheesecake, and the Athenian, out by the river, where the truckers ate. The fifth was the Plaza, on the highway in Clifton, stainless steel and blue glass, open twenty-four hours since 1979. That one he ran himself. The other four had managers, cousins and nephews, and every morning at six he drove from one to the next in a black Cadillac with a paper cup of coffee in the holder, blue and white with the Greek key on it and WE ARE HAPPY TO SERVE YOU, and tasted the soup.

He was sixty-six. He had come from a village in the hills south of Kozani at nineteen, with a cardboard suitcase and an uncle's address in Astoria, and washed dishes, and bussed tables, and fried eggs on a flat-top for eleven years before he owned a stool of his own. He married Chrysanthi from the next village over, the daughter of a saffron grower, a small round woman with skin the color of the inside of an apricot who could

add a column of figures faster than the register and was not afraid of him or of anyone. They had no children. They had the diners, and the men who worked in them, and a house on the hill in Clifton with a marble foyer that echoed when you dropped your keys.

In the old village there was a story about their two families, and the old women had told it at the wedding. In 1922, when the Greeks of Asia Minor came over the sea with nothing, burned out of Smyrna, a thousand of them walked up into the hills looking for somewhere to sleep. The big man of the district was busy with the feast of the village saint, the roasting and the dancing, and he told them to come back after the feast and shut his door. A weaver's wife met them on the road. She went through the village house by house and said, there are a thousand of them and there are a thousand houses; each house takes one. And they did, and each man built his refugee a room against his own wall, and at the end of the winter each woman gave her refugee a blanket she had woven. The weaver was Vasilis's great-grandfather and the weaver's wife was Chrysanthi's great-grandmother, by a second marriage that made it complicated, and the old women laughed and said it didn't matter, it was the same two as always, back again.

There was another story they told about themselves, a newer one. In 1974, on Good Friday, the men from the diners and their wives had gone to the Greek church in Paterson for the Lamentations. It rained. The church was full. The people who had a cousin on the parish council or a brother in the choir got in, and the diner people stood outside on the steps for three hours holding candles that kept going out. On Easter Monday Vasilis put ten thousand dollars on the table in the back booth of the Plaza and said, We are going to build our own. The others put in five thousand each, and the wives each put in twenty-five hundred, and when it ran short they all put in half again. Chrysanthi gave the new church an embroidered cover for the holy table, the yellow-orange of the saffron in her father's fields, and when the bishop came to consecrate it she stood by the iconostasis in a dress the same color and he said she looked like a lamp.

That was a long time ago. The church was full now of people's grandchildren who didn't speak Greek.

The thing about the King was that he was hungry for something and did not know what it was. He went to the liturgy every Sunday and lit candles and kissed the icons, and his heart stayed shut like a fist. He had read in the Greek paper about the Holy Mountain, about the old monks there who were said to see through you to the bottom, who could tell a man his sins before he opened his mouth, and he wanted one. He wanted one here. He sent his four nephews every Sunday to a different parish, the four of them in four directions, to Astoria and to Philadelphia and to Boston and to Chicago once on an airplane, and every Sunday night at the Plaza he asked them, *Well? Is there anyone?* And every Sunday night they said, *Theio, there's nobody. Priests with mortgages. Bishops with lawyers.*

II. Hunts Point

The Athenian, Route 46 · Thursday, September 8, 2011

It had rained for two weeks. First the hurricane at the end of August had put the Passaic over its banks at Little Falls and filled the basements of half of Paterson, and the Athenian had been closed four days with mud on the floor. Then the tail of a second storm came up from the Gulf and sat over Pennsylvania and New Jersey and rained and did not stop.

On the Thursday morning the King was at the Athenian at six-thirty, standing at the end of the counter in his raincoat tasting the lentil soup, when the produce truck from Hunts Point came in three days late. Stelios drove it. He was sixty, a Cretan with a mustache like a push broom who had brought lettuce and tomatoes and lemons to the King's diners for twenty-two years. His son Manolis rode with him, and a helper named Ramón from the Bronx who carried the cases. They came in soaked to the knees and sat at the counter and put their faces in their hands.

Where have you been? said the King. *I've got no lemons.*

Pennsylvania, Stelios said. *We went out Monday night to Scranton with a load for the Greeks at the Brothers' diner, and the roads closed behind us. Three*

nights we slept in the truck at a rest stop on 380 with the rain coming down like the end of the world. Give me coffee before you yell.

The King poured it himself. He did not ask them for news, because he had stopped expecting any, but Stelios gave it to him anyway, the way you hand over a receipt.

There's a Geronda out there.

The King stood with the coffeepot in his hand.

What did you say?

A Geronda. An elder. From the Holy Mountain. On a hill over the river past Tunkhannock. The Brothers go there.

The King put the pot down on the counter, very carefully, as if it might break. He felt it in his arms first, then his back, a cold and a heat together, the way you feel it when the anthem plays and they bring the flag in. He stood with his hand flat on the counter.

Stelio. What did you say?

I said there's a Geronda.

What did you say?

The cook came out of the kitchen to see what was wrong. Ramón looked at Manolis.

Vasili, are you deaf? A Geronda. Out past Scranton. A real one.

Say it again.

A Geronda.

The King took a paper placemat off the stack by the register, the kind with the map of Greece on it in blue and the islands like spilled crumbs, and turned it over and wrote on the back with the pen from his shirt pocket. He wrote that the Olympia diner, the building and the business and the goodwill, belonged as of this date to Stelios Daskalakis of the Bronx, and signed it, and had the cook sign it as a witness, and pushed it across the counter.

Stelios looked at it.

Is there more? said the King. *Did they say anything else?*

Vasili, sit down, you're white.

Is there more.

He teaches, said Manolis, the son, who had been listening. *The Brothers said. He sits in the yard after the service and talks, and people come from all over. They said the things he says, you go home and you can't sleep.*

Three times the King said *What?* as if he could not hear, and the fourth time he took another placemat and wrote that the Golden Star belonged as of this date to Manolis Daskalakis, and pushed it across.

Anything else?

There are monks, said Ramón. He said it in English. He was not Greek and he had understood about one word in four and he did not know why everybody was so excited. *Some monks. With beards. They live up there with him. Eight or ten. They grow tomatoes, the Brothers said. Not very good ones.*

The King heard it three times before it went in. The fourth time he wrote the Galaxy over to Ramón Tejeda of Longwood Avenue, with the cake case and the eleven kinds of cheesecake. Ramón held the placemat in both wet hands and studied it. *Mister Bill, I can't read this, it's in Greek.* The King said, *It's in English, you're holding it upside down.*

Then he stood in the middle of the Athenian with the rain coming down the windows and looked around at the men who had come out of the kitchen, the cooks and the countermen and the old dishwasher from his own village who had been with him since 1977, and his manager, and two of his nephews who had come in for breakfast, and the retired men from the old country who sat every morning in the back booth with one coffee for three hours and argued about Papandreou.

Well? he said. *What do you want to do?*

What do you want to do, Vasili?

I'm going out there, he said. *I'm not coming back. I'm going to put on the black and stay.*

The old dishwasher took off his apron and folded it and put it on the counter. *Then I'm going with you.*

That was how it went, all morning, from one diner to the next, by telephone, by word of mouth along the counters of Route 46. The legend in Astoria says a thousand men went with the King. In Clifton they say it was forty-one. They were most of them past sixty, men whose children were grown and gone to Hoboken and California and law school, men

with bad knees from forty years on tile floors and burns up their forearms from the grill. Each of them wrote something for his wife.

The King took one more placemat and wrote on the back of it to Chrysanthi.

Everything is yours. The Plaza, the house, the money, all of it. Enjoy it, my gold. Do what you want.

He folded it in four and gave it to Stelios with the keys to the Plaza, which he took off his ring. *Take this to my wife. She'll give you something for your trouble. If she asks where I went, tell her I went to the Geronda for good.*

III. Three Rivers

Little Falls to Tunkhannock · Thursday afternoon, September 8

They left from the Plaza lot at one o'clock in the afternoon in nineteen cars, Cadillacs and Lincolns and the dishwasher's Buick and somebody's son-in-law's minivan, with the King in front, and the rain coming down so hard the wipers could not keep it off the glass.

The first river was the Passaic. Where the road came down to it at Little Falls it was over its banks again, brown and fast, carrying lawn chairs, and the police had the road shut with sawhorses and flashing lights.

How deep? the King asked the officer.

Over the guardrail, sir. You can't go through. Nobody's going through today.

Is there another way?

Not today, sir.

The King sat in the Cadillac with the engine running. It was the first time in his life he had been told no and did not mind. While we sit here looking for another road, he thought, we get older, and one day we die looking. He had renounced everything for Christ. What would the water do to him? He put both hands on the wheel and said aloud, in the old words, *Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me,* and drove around the sawhorses. The officer shouted. Nineteen cars followed him through.

The policeman told the story afterward to anyone who would buy him a drink. He said the cars went across the flooded road as if it were dry

pavement, single file, at thirty miles an hour, and they threw no spray. Not a drop. He said he walked out to the edge of it after they had gone and the water came up over his shoes.

The second river was the Delaware, at the Water Gap, high and the color of coffee with milk, eating at the roads along its banks. The King said, *Thy law is a lamp to my feet, and a light to my paths,* and thought of the Gospel book on the holy table under Chrysanthi's yellow cloth, and they crossed.

The third was the Susquehanna, at Tunkhannock, in the dark. It was rising toward the highest it had ever been, and the low parts of the town along it were being emptied, and the sirens went up and down. The King thought of the Church, the whole of it, the dead with the living, the monks on the Holy Mountain, the old women in black lighting candles in every village from Kozani to Clifton, the forty men in the cars behind him. He said, *Save thy people, and bless thine inheritance,* and drove down to the water where the road went under it, and across.

On the far side, on the bank above the flood, there was a sycamore, a big one, white in the dark like a bone. And under the sycamore a man in black was sitting on a folding chair.

He was not old. That was the first thing they noticed afterward, all of them. He was thirty-eight, with a black beard and round glasses, a big plain man who looked like he might have played tackle in high school, which he had, in Astoria, before Columbia and the engineering degree and the fifteen years on the Holy Mountain. The monks called him Geronda anyway, because that is what the word means, the one you go to, and his name was Father Isaak.

And the light came from him. The men all said so afterward, separately, and the ones who were not given to saying such things said it too. Out of the rain and the dark there was a light under the sycamore of no particular color and every color, and the white branches of the tree over him looked gold, as if they had been laid with gold leaf like the background of an icon, every twig. The King thought: it isn't headlights. It isn't the fire trucks. It isn't the moon. He got out of the car and stood in the rain, and walked toward the light the way you walk into the sea, and

went down on both knees in the mud in front of the folding chair, and the forty men behind him got down too.

I was told you'd come today, Father Isaak said. *Get up. You'll ruin your pants.*

He talked to them there under the tree for an hour in the rain, and they listened, and none of them could say afterward exactly what he said. It was about the Kingdom of Heaven, and about how it is like a man who finds a treasure in a field and goes and sells everything he has, and about how none of them had ever owned anything in the first place, the diners or the houses or their own bodies, and how it was a great relief to find that out. The King felt the fist in his chest open. That was all he could say about it ever. It opened, the way his hand opened when he set down the coffeepot.

When Father Isaak stopped talking they asked him, all of them, to take them in.

He looked at them a long time, these old men from the counters, in their wet golf jackets, with their bad knees in the mud.

Come on, then, he said, and stood up and folded his chair.

That night they slept in the guesthouse of the monastery on the ridge, two to a room on cots. And in the morning, the men who had shaved the day before for forty years came down to the church with beards. Long ones, grey, down to their chests, as if they had been monks on the Holy Mountain for forty years and had not cut them once. The dishwasher from the village could not stop touching his. The King looked at himself in the black window of the church door and did not know who it was. The monks of the monastery, the eight or ten of them, came out and stood in a row in the yard and looked at the forty old men with beards to their belts, and one of the young monks said quietly, *Christ and the Panagia,* and the others did not say anything.

IV. The Placemat

Clifton · Thursday night and Friday, September 9

STELIOS BROUGHT THE PLACEMAT UP THE HILL THAT NIGHT IN the produce truck. He rang the bell, and Chrysanthi Kappas opened the door herself in her housecoat, and he stood in the marble foyer dripping and handed it to her.

She read the map of Greece side first, then turned it over.

What is this?

He told her about the diner, and the coffeepot, and the three placemats.

He gave you the Olympia, she said. *For that.*

Yes, kyria.

For a word.

For a word.

What word?

There's a Geronda, Stelios said. *Out past Scranton. A real one.*

And it took her exactly the way it had taken him. She felt it in her arms, then the back of her neck. She put her hand on the newel post and said, *What did you say?* three times, and Stelios said it three times, and the fourth time she said, *He gave you the Olympia for that? That's nothing. That's a cheap man. My husband was always a cheap man.* And she went to the desk in the hall where she kept the papers for everything, and wrote on the back of an electric bill that the building on Main Avenue in Passaic, the one with the bakery and the four apartments upstairs, belonged as of this date to Stelios Daskalakis, and his son got the shore house at Seaside Heights, and Ramón, who had stayed in the truck because he was embarrassed, got the parking lot behind the Plaza and the mortgage the Plaza paid on it every month for ninety-nine years.

Where is he?

He went to the Geronda, kyria. He said for good.

And the others? The old ones from the back booth? Kostas? The dishwasher?

Forty of them. In the cars.

She telephoned the wives. They came up the hill in the morning in the rain, in their good raincoats and their gold earrings, women of sixty and seventy who had worked the registers, baked the pies, raised the children, buried the parents. They stood in her foyer while she read them the placemat.

Your husbands sent you messages too, she said. *Everybody's got a placemat. They gave you everything. The houses, the money, enjoy it. That's what they say.*

And you, Chrysanthi? What are you going to do?

Chrysanthi folded her husband's placemat in four again and put it in the pocket of her housecoat.

Forty years he stood in that Plaza, and I stood next to him, and we were never happy one day, not the way they mean it in church. He was hungry and I was hungry and we fed everybody on Route 46 and we were hungry. Now he got up and spat it out. All of it. The diners and this house and the money, he spat it out on the floor like a bad olive. She looked around at the marble foyer. *Am I going to get down on my knees and pick it up and put it in my mouth? What he spat out?*

Nobody said anything.

I'm going after him, she said. *I don't want any of this either.*

Then we're going too.

Can you do it? It's not a vacation. You'll have to leave everything.

We can do it.

Then go put on something you can walk in, said Chrysanthi.

They left at noon in a line of cars as long as the men's had been. At Little Falls the road was still shut, and she asked the policeman, the same one, how deep, and he said what he had said, and then he said, *Lady, yesterday forty cars went across here. I saw it. I'm not supposed to say so.*

Look for their tracks, Chrysanthi told the women in her car.

They looked. Where the flood came up over the road, the mud on the near side had been smoothed by the water, and there was nothing on it. Not a tire mark. Not one.

Then he didn't drive across, she said. *He said a prayer and the water carried him. He said, I left everything for Christ, so let the water be no water to me.*

That's what he said, I know him. She put both hands on the wheel the way he did. *So I left everything too.*

So the women crossed the Passaic, and then the Delaware, and late that night the Susquehanna, near the highest it had ever been. The outer edges of their tires came out dry.

V. The Sycamore

The Monastery of the Prophet Elias, Wyoming County, Pennsylvania · Saturday, September 10

Father Isaak knew they were coming. He did not say how. On Saturday morning, when the radio said the Susquehanna had gone higher at Wilkes-Barre than it had ever gone and was only now beginning to fall, he went into the guesthouse and told the forty new old men with their long grey beards to go into the church, all of them, and stay there, and keep quiet. He shut the doors behind them.

Why, Geronda? said the young monk who kept the gate.

Because their wives are coming, he said. *And if a woman who has been married forty years sees her husband come out of a door with a beard to his belly in a black riassa, the first day, she will either laugh or faint, and either way she won't hear one word I say to her. Let her hear first. Then she can see.*

The women had slept in their cars at the bottom of the ridge road. In the morning they came up it and parked in the mud. Father Isaak was waiting for them under the sycamore at the bottom of the hill, where the flood had come up to the roots in the night and gone down again, leaving a line of leaves and bottles. The women saw the light the men had seen, the gold in the white branches and the light of no color under them. Chrysanthi got out of her car and walked into it and knelt. The others knelt behind her.

Father, she said. *I think my husband came here. Vasilis Kappas. He said he came to stay with you. Where is he? Show him to us.*

Sit down, he said. *Right here. You'll see him. You'll see all of them.*

The women sat on the wet grass and on the hoods of their cars, glad, thinking in a minute they would see their husbands. Father Isaak talked to them for an hour, the way he had talked to the men. Chrysanthi could

not remember afterward any more than the King could what he said, but she remembered that at a certain point in it she stopped thinking about her husband at all, and about the house and the marble foyer and the Plaza, and that something in her came loose, as if a thread had been cut, and that it did not hurt.

Up the hill in the church, behind the shut doors, the forty old men were listening through the windows, which were open a crack because of the damp. They heard everything Father Isaak said to their wives. And the old dishwasher from the village said later that while they listened, standing in the dark church in their new black clothes with the candles going, the last thing in them that was still holding on to anything let go. He said you could hear it, like knuckles cracking all over the church at once.

When he was finished Father Isaak looked up the hill and nodded, and the young monk at the gate opened the church doors, and the men came out.

They came down the hill in a line in black, with their long grey beards, slowly, because of their knees. Their wives stood up. Nobody laughed and nobody fainted. Chrysanthi looked at her husband a long time, coming down the wet grass toward her with his beard on his chest and the light on his face, and she did not see the King of Route 46 in him anywhere, and she was glad.

She went down on her knees in front of him in the mud and kissed his hand, the way you kiss a priest's.

So, she said. *You got there.*

Ti chará, he said. That was all. *Ti chará.* What joy.

The women asked Father Isaak to take them too. Father Isaak said, *Not here. This is a house for men. There are sisters in the mountains of North Carolina, in a monastery of the Annunciation, the abbess is a hard old Cretan who will work you like mules and you'll love her. Go there.*

So the women went. They went in their cars, slowly, by the old roads, and it took them nine days. At every town with a Greek church they stopped, in Harrisburg, Baltimore, Richmond, Charlotte, and every time the people of the parish were already waiting on the steps to feed them

and put them up for the night and send them on in the morning with food for the road, as if the news had gone down the highway ahead of them. Nobody ever found out who carried it. Chrysanthi drove the first car. When they came at last up the gravel road to the sisters in the mountains, the old Cretan abbess was standing at the gate with her arms folded, and she looked at Chrysanthi a long time and said, *You're the one with the saffron,* and Chrysanthi had never seen her before in her life.

VI. Ti Chará

The Monastery of the Prophet Elias · winter 2011–12

MONKS ARE NOT SUPPOSED TO TALK MUCH, AND MOSTLY THE old men from the diners did not. They worked. They were used to working. They took over the kitchen and the monastery started eating very well for the first time in its history, and they rebuilt the guesthouse porch, and the dishwasher from the village grew tomatoes against the south wall of the church that were, for the first time, very good tomatoes.

The King had been given a new name with the black, Varnavas. But everyone at the monastery went on thinking of him as the King, and he did not mind that either.

He went around saying it. In the morning in the dark on his way to the church, and at the woodpile, and in the kitchen with his sleeves pushed up, and walking the ridge road in the snow in the afternoon with his hands behind his back and his beard blowing. *Ti chará. Ti chará.* What joy. What joy. Not loudly. To himself, the way a man hums.

The younger monks talked about it. They had been there before the old men came, and some of them had given up very little to get there, a graduate fellowship, a girlfriend, a Honda Civic, and they were not sure what to make of forty retired diner men who had given up Route 46. One of them went to Father Isaak after Vespers.

Geronda, Father Varnavas is going around all day saying, What joy, what joy.

Yes.

We think he's remembering. The diners. The Plaza on a Sunday morning after church, everybody waiting for a booth. His Cadillac. He was a big man. We think it's hard for him.

Father Isaak sent for him. The King came in from the woodpile with chips of oak in his beard.

Varnava. They tell me you're going around saying, What joy. They think you miss the Plaza.

The King thought about it honestly, the way he had tasted the soup every morning at six.

Geronda, he said. *You know what I'm talking about. You tell them.*

Father Isaak looked at the young monks a while.

He doesn't miss the Plaza, he said. *He isn't talking about the Plaza. He drank something and it went down into him and now he can't stop being glad. He's talking about that. He's talking about God.*

And he said it to them out of the psalter, the old Greek one in English, the way he said everything, as if it were plain information, like the time of Vespers.

> *They shall be fully satisfied with the fatness of thine house; and thou shalt cause them to drink of the full stream of thy delights. For with thee is the fountain of life: in thy light we shall see light.*
>
> *— Psalm 35:9–10 (Septuagint)*

And the first psalm, he said. *You know it.*

> *But his pleasure is in the law of the Lord; and in his law will he meditate day and night.*
>
> *— Psalm 1:2 (Septuagint)*

The King went back out to the woodpile. Through the window they could see him split one log and set the halves on the stack and stand for a moment in the snow with the maul on his shoulder, saying it.

• • •

The Olympia is still on Route 46, and so are the Golden Star and the Galaxy, though the cake case has stopped revolving and the cheesecake is down to six kinds. Stelios ran the Olympia until he died, and Manolis runs it now, and Ramón Tejeda of Longwood Avenue owns the Galaxy outright and has learned to read the Greek on the menu, though not much else of it. The Plaza was sold. It is a bank.

At the Olympia, under the glass on the counter beside the register, where other diners keep the business cards of the plumber and the snapshot of the owner shaking hands with a mayor, there is a paper placemat with a map of Greece on it in blue, and the islands scattered across the sea like crumbs. It has been folded in four and opened out again. If you ask Manolis, he lifts the glass and turns it over for you. On the back, in a big square hand in ballpoint, it says the Olympia belongs to his father, as of September 8, 2011, and under that someone has written in another pen, smaller, in Greek, two words.

Background

The verse

> *He who drinks in the law lives happily with a serene mind: the sage rejoices always in the law, as preached by the elect (Ariyas).*
>
> Dhammapada 79, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Mahā Kappina of Kukkuṭavatī sends riders out every day for news that a Buddha has appeared. When weary traders arriving from Sāvatthī tell him that the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Saṅgha have appeared, he is so overcome he must hear each word four times, and rewards them with a hundred thousand coins for each. He sends his kingdom to Queen Anojā on a plate of gold and sets out with his thousand courtiers to go forth; they cross three rivers on horseback without wetting the horses' hooves, by recollecting the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Saṅgha, and find the Buddha waiting under a banyan, shining. Anojā rewards the traders three times as much, refuses to "take into her mouth" the glory her husband has spat out, and follows with the courtiers' wives, finding no hoofprints at the rivers. The Buddha hides the new monks until the women are steady, then sends the women to the nuns at Sāvatthī. Afterward Kappina goes about exclaiming "Oh, happiness!" and the monks suppose he misses being king; the Buddha says he has drunk

the Dhamma. A past-life frame tells of a weaver's wife who housed a thousand holy men a king had turned away during a festival, and of householders, caught in the rain without friends inside a monastery, who built one of their own. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kappina and Queen Anojā.

Clifton, New Jersey

Route 46 and the Susquehanna, 2011

New Jersey has called itself the diner capital of the world since its factories built the prefabricated lunch cars of the early twentieth century, and by the late century most of its diners were owned by Greek immigrant families, many of whom had started as dishwashers and countermen. The blue-and-white Anthora coffee cup, with its Greek key and amphora and WE ARE HAPPY TO SERVE YOU, was designed in 1963 for Greek-owned coffee shops in New York. The King's family story reaches back to 1922, when Greek refugees from Asia Minor poured into Greece after the war with Turkey, ahead of the population exchange. A gerondas is an elder, often a monk of long experience, sought out for spiritual counsel.

In early September 2011, days after Hurricane Irene had flooded the Passaic valley, the remnants of Tropical Storm Lee stalled over the Northeast. On September 8 and 9 the Passaic flooded again at Little Falls, the Delaware ran at moderate flood stage, and the Susquehanna rose to a record of more than 42 feet at Wilkes-Barre, forcing the evacuation of tens of thousands along its banks, from Binghamton and Tunkhannock down to Harrisburg. The psalms the abbot quotes are from Sir Lancelot Brenton's 1844 English translation of the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, whose numbering of the Psalms is the one the Orthodox Church uses (text).

After the story of the Elder Mahā Kappina from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 79). The original. Scripture from Brenton's translation of the Septuagint (1844). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

6.5

Four Redfish

> *He that is slow to anger is better than the mighty; and he that ruleth his spirit than he that taketh a city.*
> *— Proverbs 16:32*

Here's how it was told to me, on Forty-Seventh Street.

I. Big Poor

Pass Christian, Mississippi · 1903

The family tells it starting with Isom Pruitt, who was so poor that everybody on the Coast called him Big Poor, and he answered to it.

That was the year the Moderator came down from Jackson for the District Association, with twenty preachers behind him and a choir from Hattiesburg, and the whole Black side of Pass Christian turned itself inside out to feed them. On the Sunday before, at Mount Pilgrim, the church clerk, Brother Toles, stood up after the sermon with a ledger book and a pencil, and he said that the Moderator had taught them something that morning. He said there is the man who gives and does not ask anybody else to give, and he will have plenty but nobody beside him. And there is the man who asks everybody else to give and gives nothing, and he will have friends but no bread. And there is the man who does neither, and he will eat what other people leave. And there is the man who gives and gets his neighbors giving too, and he will have bread and company both. Brother Toles said he meant to be that last kind of man. Then he went up and down the aisles writing down how many preachers each family would feed.

Two, said the Battles, who had the oyster house and the ice house. *Five,* said the Battles' cousins. One family said ten. Brother Toles wrote them all down in a column.

Big Poor was standing at the back by the door, because he did not own a coat good enough to sit down in. Brother Toles came to him last, and Big Poor said, *Brother Toles, what have I got to do with preachers? Preachers want feeding by people with something. I haven't got meal for my own children tomorrow.*

Brother Toles could have let it go. But a man who asks other people to give has to be careful how he asks. He said: *Isom, look around this church. There are people in here who eat fried chicken on a Tuesday. You work harder than any of them and you never have a dime. Did you ever think maybe the reason you never have anything is that you never gave anything away?*

Big Poor stood there a while. Then his eyes filled up and he said, *Put me down for one. However little I make, I will feed one preacher.*

Brother Toles looked at the ledger, and looked at Big Poor's shoes, and thought, *What's the use of writing down one,* and he did not write it.

Big Poor went home and told his wife, Hettie, and she did not say what another woman might have said. She said, *You did right. We're poor because we never gave. We'll both hire out tomorrow, and we'll feed him.*

So on Monday he split stove wood for Mr. Aurelius Battle, who was the richest colored man on the Coast and was feeding thirty preachers himself, and he split it so hard and so fast, axe and then hatchet and then axe again, that Mr. Battle came out on the gallery to watch. *Isom, I never saw you work like that. I'm feeding a preacher Sunday, Mr. Battle.* And Mr. Battle was pleased, and thought, *That's a hard thing he's taken on,* and paid him four dollars where he had said two. Out back, Hettie did Mrs. Battle's washing on a rub-board, singing over the tub as if she were at a dance, and Mrs. Battle asked her why, and when she heard, she gave her coffee and flour and lard and a sack of rice and a jar of fig preserves besides her pay.

On Saturday morning Hettie sent him for greens. There were none at the store, so he went down along the bayou picking wild mustard and poke, and he sang while he picked, because he was going to feed a

preacher. Down at the mouth of the bayou an old fisherman named Dave Lyle was hauling a seine, and he knew that voice.

Isom! What are you so happy about, picking weeds?

I'm feeding a preacher tomorrow.

Lord help that preacher, eating your weeds. But he called him down, and set him to stringing mullet and croakers on palmetto strips to sell for a nickel and a dime, and all day the women of Pass Christian came down to the beach and bought fish for the preachers they were feeding, and Big Poor strung until it was all gone. Then Dave Lyle went to a place above the tide line and dug in the wet sand with his hands and brought up four redfish he had buried there to keep cool for his own Sunday dinner, each one as long as a man's arm, with the black spot on the tail.

If you mean to feed a preacher, he said, *you can't feed him weeds. Take these.*

II. The Bible

Pass Christian · Sunday

That same Saturday evening a tall man in a white jacket like a dining-car waiter came walking up the shell road to Big Poor's cabin and asked if anybody needed help. He said he could cook anything. Big Poor said they could not pay him. The man said a man feeding a preacher shouldn't have to pay for a cook, and wasn't it right to do a good thing when you saw one, and he went in and took the redfish from Hettie and sent everybody else out of the kitchen.

On Sunday after preaching, Brother Toles went down the ledger column and sent each preacher off with the family that had him. Big Poor stood waiting with his hat in his hands until the churchyard was empty, and then he went up to the clerk.

Brother Toles. Where's my preacher?

Brother Toles put his hand over his mouth. *Isom. I didn't write you down.*

The family says it went into Big Poor like a knife. He said, *You told me to give. My wife and I worked all week for hire. I was on the bayou since daylight picking greens. Give me one preacher.* And he wrung his hands and

cried right there in the churchyard, a grown man, and people came back to see what it was, and when they heard, they turned on Brother Toles and asked him what kind of a clerk raises up a poor man's hopes and then forgets him. Brother Toles said every preacher was gone already and he couldn't take one out of anybody's house. *But the Moderator is still in the parsonage,* he said, *washing his face. Go to him. Tell him you're poor. He's always had a soft place for poor folks.*

The yard of the parsonage was full of important people. Mr. Battle was there, and the undertaker, and the principal of the colored school, and two lawyers from Gulfport, all waiting to walk the Moderator to dinner. They said, *Isom, what are you doing here? Dinner's not handed out at the back door today.* Big Poor said, *I didn't come for dinner.* He went up the steps and knelt down on the porch boards outside the Moderator's door and put his forehead on the sill.

There's nobody on this Coast poorer than me, he said through the door. *Have mercy on me.*

The Moderator opened the door. He was an old man with white hair, and he did not say anything. He took his Bible from under his arm, the big one with the brass corners that he preached out of, and put it in Big Poor's hands.

Everybody in the yard sucked in their breath. To carry the Moderator's Bible to dinner meant the Moderator was eating at your table. Mr. Battle said, *Isom, let me carry that. I'll give you ten dollars for it.* The lawyers offered fifteen, and then twenty-five. Big Poor held the Bible against his chest and said he didn't want money, he wanted to feed the man, and they could not take it from him, because nobody takes from a man what the Moderator himself has put in his hands. But Mr. Battle walked along behind them, thinking that when he saw what Big Poor had cooked he would take the old man home to a proper table.

Big Poor's cabin had a door so low that he had to stoop to go in his own house. The Moderator did not stoop. He walked in standing straight, and nobody who was there could ever agree afterward whether the floor went down or the lintel went up, only that he did not bend his neck and did not hit his head.

Inside, the tall man in the white jacket had set a chair at the table with a clean flour sack across it. He took the lids off the pots. There was redfish fried and redfish baked in red gravy and rice and the greens from the bayou cooked down with fatback, and biscuits, and the fig preserves. The smell went out the door and up the shell road and over the whole town, and people at their own tables in Pass Christian put down their forks and lifted their heads.

Mr. Battle looked at the table a long time. Then he said, *Moderator, I came here thinking I'd take you away to my house. I've never seen a table like this in my life. If I stay, I'll shame him.* And he took off his hat and went.

When the Moderator had eaten and given thanks, he got up to leave, and the tall man nodded to Big Poor to carry the Bible and walk him back. Then the tall man stood in the cabin door and looked up at the sky.

It rained silver dollars. The family is plain about this. It rained silver dollars into that cabin until the pots were full and the drawers were full and the floor was covered to the knee, and Hettie had to carry the children out on her hips and stand them in the yard. When Big Poor came back from the parsonage he found them all standing outside in their Sunday clothes, and the cook was gone, and nobody ever saw him again.

Big Poor went straight to Mr. Battle and said, *Mr. Battle, my house is full of money. Come take it.* It took Mr. Battle's oyster wagons all night to haul it, and they piled it in his yard, and the pile was as high as a chinaberry tree. On Monday he called the people together and asked if anybody on the Coast had money like that. They said nobody did. *Then he's the rich man now,* said Mr. Battle, and that is how Big Poor came to be called Mr. Pruitt. Mr. Battle sold him the lot where the old Eustis house had burned, and when Big Poor's sons were clearing the ground to build on it, their shovels struck the rims of buried crocks, one after another, mouth to mouth in a row, full of gold. Mr. Battle said that was his luck and his only. Big Poor built his house. Then he fed the whole Association, preachers and choir and all, for seven days.

III. Solomon

South Side, Chicago · 1944–1952

Big Poor lived to be seventy-one. His son Royal took a share of the money north in 1922 and opened Pruitt & Sons Funeral Home on Forty-Seventh Street, with a Cadillac hearse and a chapel that seated a hundred, and every Baptist church on the South Side had Pruitt & Sons on the cardboard fans in its pews, with a picture of Jesus in the garden on one side and the telephone number on the other. Royal's daughter Odessa married a man who taught printing at the trade school, and the Pruitts were among the people who kept Deacon Lucius Mabry in barber chairs and kept his church in folding chairs, and had for twenty years.

Big Poor died in Pass Christian in the winter of 1944. That same winter Odessa found out she was carrying a child.

Her craving was not for pickles. She told her mother that she wanted, more than anything, to fry redfish for the whole church, the choicest pieces, and serve the deacons and the mothers' board with her own hands, and then put on a plain white usher's dress and sit on the last bench in the back and eat whatever they left. Her mother laughed at her and then telephoned to Gulfport, and a barrel of redfish came up on the Illinois Central packed in ice, and Odessa had her way. After that she did it seven times more before the baby came.

He was born in August of 1945, the week the war ended. When Deacon Mabry came to the house to pray over him and asked what they were calling him, Odessa said: *From the day I knew he was coming, Uncle Tal, who hasn't said a sensible thing since he came back from France in 1918, started talking sense at the supper table. Aunt Bert, who's deaf, heard the radio. My husband's brother quit drinking. His name is Solomon.*

The old women at church held him and looked into his face and said what old women from Mississippi say about some babies. *That child's been here before.* Some of them said, privately, which old man they thought it was.

Odessa made up her mind the day he was born that she would never stand in the way of anything he wanted. And for seven years he did not want very much.

IV. Seeking

Forty-Seventh Street · July 1952

It was the polio summer, the worst one anybody could remember, and Odessa kept Solomon out of the public pools along with every other mother on the South Side. He spent July in the barbershop, sitting on the shoeshine stand and watching Deacon Mabry cut hair.

One evening at supper he put down his fork and said, *Mama, I want to go seeking. I want Deacon Mabry for my spiritual father.*

In some of the old country churches back home, children went seeking when they were old enough to know what they were asking for. They went off by themselves to pray, in the woods or the cotton, for days, and told their dreams every evening to an old man or woman of the church they had picked for their spiritual father or mother, who listened and said, *Not yet,* or *Keep on,* until the morning the child came back with a face that showed it had come through, and the church took them in. Most of the churches in Chicago had let it go. Deacon Mabry's church had not. It met in a storefront on Forty-Seventh Street that had been a shoe store, with the old pastor's name painted on the glass, and it still kept a mourners' bench up front, a plank bench with no back.

Solomon was seven. Odessa looked at her husband, and her husband looked at his plate.

All right, baby, she said. *I said I'd never stop you.*

She invited Deacon Mabry to Sunday dinner and told him. Then she called her people and said they would be doing a fish fry for the whole church, all week, every night of the revival, and she sent to Gulfport for the redfish.

Deacon Mabry did not make it sound easy. He sat Solomon on the chair across from him and told him what seeking was. No ball. No picture show. No Regal Theater on Saturday, no funny papers, no running with

the other boys. You pray, and you watch, and you tell me what you see, and if I say keep on, you keep on.

Yes, sir, said Solomon. *I'll do what you tell me.*

Then come on.

On Monday he put the boy in his own barber chair and wet his hair down with the water bottle and cut it close to the scalp, the way you cut a boy's hair for summer. While he cut, he gave him his first lesson. *Start with what the Lord gave you that you can see,* he said. *Your hair. Your fingernails. Your teeth. Your skin. Study on them. Where did they come from. Whose are they. What do they do when you're not telling them anything.* Solomon sat very still under the cloth and looked at his own hair falling in the mirror.

All that week the Pruitts fried redfish in the church kitchen every night of the revival and fed everybody who came, the old pastor first, and Odessa sat in the back in her white usher's dress and ate last.

V. Three Things

The eighth day

On the eighth morning Deacon Mabry took the boy with him on his rounds.

He did not go out with the other deacons, who had left early to visit the sick and the shut-in and would eat where they were fed. He went late. First he opened the church himself, and swept the floor where nobody had swept it, and filled the water cooler, and set the folding chairs back in their rows where the revival had knocked them every which way, because the Holiness church was right across the street and he did not mean to give them a chance to say that Baptists keep a dirty house. Then he showed Solomon how to carry a Bible properly, the deacon's big one, against the chest with both arms and not swinging by the cover, and how to walk on a street beside a grown man, and they went out.

It was hot already. The L went over at Forty-Seventh like a long iron roll of thunder.

In a vacant lot on Evans Avenue an old man in overalls had planted collards and okra and tomatoes in rows, the way he had planted them in

Mississippi, and he was watering. He had a hose run from a basement window, and he did not spray it. He laid it down at the top of the row and let the water run, and walked beside it with a hoe, and wherever it wanted to spill over he scraped a little dirt and turned it, and the water went down the row where he led it, and around the end, and back up the next.

Deacon, what's he doing?

Watering his greens. Leading the water down the rows.

Does water have a mind?

No, son. Water hasn't got a mind.

But he can lead it wherever he wants.

Look like it.

Solomon walked on and did not say anything. He was thinking that if a man could lead water, that had no mind, wherever he wanted it to go, then a person who had a mind ought to be able to lead his own.

Further on, in the window of Madam Estelle's beauty shop, a woman in a pink smock was pressing hair. She had a steel comb heating on the little gas plate beside her chair, and she took it off the flame and touched it to a damp towel so it hissed, and drew it slow through a girl's hair from the root out, and the hair came out behind the comb lying straight and shining, and the girl held her ear down with her finger and did not move.

What's she doing, Deacon?

Pressing that girl's hair.

Does hair know anything?

No more than water.

Solomon put his hand up to his own head, where the hair was a quarter-inch long and his. If heat and a steady hand could straighten what had no mind, he thought, why couldn't he straighten what did.

At the corner of Prairie there was a bicycle shop with Schwinns hung up by their front wheels in the window, and in the doorway a man had a bent wheel off a boy's bicycle clamped in a stand. He spun it and watched where the rim wobbled against a pointer, and stopped it, and turned a spoke a little with a key, and spun it again, sighting along it with one eye shut. Every time he spun it, it wobbled less. Then it did not wobble.

Does that wheel have a mind?

Son, a wheel hasn't got a mind.

Solomon stood there with the Bible against his chest and watched the wheel go around, true, humming, until the man put his hand on the tire and stopped it. Then he turned to Deacon Mabry and held out the Bible.

Deacon, would you take your Bible, please, sir. I want to go back.

Deacon Mabry had been a deacon for thirty-one years, and he could have said, *Boy, who do you think you're talking to, the pastor?* He did not say it. He did not even think it. He said, *Hand it here,* and took his Bible.

And Deacon. When you come back, will you bring me something to eat? Redfish.

Son, where am I going to find redfish in Chicago in July?

If you can't get it on your account, said Solomon, *you'll get it on mine.*

Deacon Mabry thought that a boy alone in the street on a polio summer might come to harm, so he took the key to the church off his ring and gave it to him. *Go in and lock the door behind you. Don't open it for anybody but me.*

VI. Still

Forty-Seventh Street · noon

SOLOMON LET HIMSELF INTO THE STOREFRONT AND LOCKED the door and sat down on the mourners' bench in the half-dark behind the painted glass, and put his hands on his knees and looked at them. Then he closed his eyes and looked at them anyway. He looked at his hair and his fingernails and his teeth and his skin, the way the Deacon had told him, and then he went further in, and began to lead his own mind down the row where he wanted it, and every time it spilled over he turned it back.

This is the part people on Forty-Seventh Street still argue about.

They say that a little after noon the pigeons all got up off the roof of the Regal Theater at once and flew east toward the lake and did not come back. They say that four policemen, nobody knew from what station, came and stood one on each corner of the block where the storefront

was, in their summer uniforms, and turned the traffic down the side streets with their white gloves, and would not say why. They say the L stopped. It stopped up on its tracks over Forty-Seventh Street with the people still in it and did not move, and the people in the cars did not complain, and the motorman sat with his hands in his lap. They say that a tall man in a white jacket, like a dining-car waiter, came from somewhere and stood with his back to the church door and his arms folded, and that when the ice man came by with his tongs he took one look at the tall man and went around. They say the sun stopped over the street at a little past noon and stayed there. Nobody's shadow moved. There was not a sound on the whole block, not a radio, not a screen door, not a dry leaf on the sidewalk.

Inside, the boy on the bench went down into himself as easy as a man walking into still water, and kept going.

Deacon Mabry, meanwhile, was thinking that the boy was alone and hungry and that he knew a house where he could get something to carry back. He went to Sister Ola Bell Crump's apartment on Vincennes, three flights up, because Sister Crump had loved him since he baptized her daughter and he knew it. When she opened the door, the whole hallway smelled of frying fish.

Deacon! Come in here. We were just now sitting here waiting for somebody. My sister sent a box up from Gulfport on the train this morning, redfish, packed in ice, and I said to Junior, now who in Chicago am I going to give all this fish to?

They sat him down and fed him. When he told them what he had come for, Sister Crump said, *You eat first, Deacon, and you'll carry some away besides,* and when he had eaten she filled a plate with the best pieces, the thick part behind the head, and covered it with a dish towel. Deacon Mabry thanked her and went down the three flights faster than he had come up, because the boy must be hungry.

The old pastor was already sitting outside the storefront when he got there.

His name was the Reverend Elias Tolliver. He was eighty-one, and had preached in Mississippi before he preached in Chicago, and he had eaten

his breakfast early that morning and come down on the streetcar and set a folding chair in front of the church door, right in front of it, as if he were sitting in the door of a tent. Afterward he told them he could not stay in his chair at home. He sat in the heat with his hat on his knee and watched the Deacon come down the block with the plate.

Deacon. What you got there?

Fish, Reverend. For the boy.

What does fish do?

Deacon Mabry looked at him. *Fills you up. Makes you feel good.*

And what does feeling good do?

Puts a shine on you, Reverend. Puts some meat on your bones.

And what does that shine do?

Deacon Mabry thought about it, because the old man was waiting, and the old man did not ask questions he did not want answered. *Lets you lay down easy at night,* he said. *Lets you sit down easy anywhere you sit.*

Reverend Tolliver nodded as if that were the right answer, which it was.

And behind the painted glass, in the minute it took to ask four questions and answer them, the boy on the mourners' bench came through. People who were there say that is the only way to put it. He came through, and he came through with understanding, the way an old person comes through, so that afterward when grown people brought him their dreams and their troubles he could tell them what they meant, and what they ought to do, and say it in words they could use.

Go on, said Reverend Tolliver, and moved his chair aside. *Give the boy his fish.*

Deacon Mabry knocked. Solomon unlocked the door and came out into the light. He took the plate from the Deacon's hands with both of his, and set it down on the folding chair inside the door, and took one of the Pruitt & Sons fans out of the rack on the back of a pew, his own grandfather's name on one side and Jesus in the garden on the other, and began to fan the Deacon, slowly, the way the ushers fan the old mothers when it gets hot in church.

Son, sit down and eat.

What about you, Deacon?

I already ate. You eat yours.

So the boy sat down on the mourners' bench with the plate on his knees, seven years old, eight days a seeker, and ate his redfish, and his face looked like a morning glory on a back fence just after it opens.

VII. Dark

Forty-Seventh Street · evening

When he had eaten, he took the plate to the little sink in the back and washed it and dried it and put it on the shelf.

Then the L started. The pigeons came back over the roof of the Regal all at once in a long grey sheet. The four policemen walked off in four directions and nobody ever found out what station they were from. The tall man was not at the door. And the sun, which had been standing over the street since a little past noon, went down like a stone dropped in a well, all at once, so that the streetlights along Forty-Seventh Street came on by themselves, and in the kitchenettes up and down the block women came to the windows holding dishrags to see what had happened.

Some of the church people were put out about it. They said it got dark in the middle of the day and the Pruitt boy had only just eaten his breakfast, and what kind of a thing was that. They said it to Reverend Tolliver that night before the revival service, on the sidewalk outside the storefront, and he heard them out.

Yes, he said. *While that boy was in there seeking, the sun stood still over this street, and the police held the corners, and somebody stood at the door. And I could not sit in my own house. I came down here and sat in the door of the church to keep watch over my son.*

Then he told them about the three things the boy had seen. A man leading water down the rows. A woman with a hot comb, straightening what does not know it is being straightened. A man truing a wheel with one eye shut. *Things that haven't got a mind,* he said. *And a child looked at them and took hold of the one thing he's got that does.*

He went inside, and stood up behind the table that served for a pulpit, and before he did anything else he read them one verse.

> *He that is slow to anger is better than the mighty; and he that ruleth his spirit than he that taketh a city.*
>
> *— Proverbs 16:32*

That was the last night of the revival. Eleven people came to the mourners' bench, grown men among them, and the old women said afterward that nine of them came through before the summer was over.

• • •

Solomon was still sitting in the back row when the service let out. The streetlights were on. Across Forty-Seventh Street the bicycle man had left his stand out in the doorway, with somebody's front wheel still in it, and on the way home the boy stopped and gave it a turn with one finger, and watched it go around in the light from the street, true, without a sound, until it stopped by itself.

Background

The verse

> *Well-makers lead the water (wherever they like); fletchers bend the arrow; carpenters bend a log of wood; wise people fashion themselves.*
>
> Dhammapada 80, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary opens in a past age with a man so poor he is called Mahā Duggata, the Great Pauper. When a neighbor goes around writing down how many monks each household will feed, the pauper pledges one and is left off the list. He and his wife hire themselves out, a fisherman gives him four redfish, and Sakka, king of the gods, comes disguised as a cook. The Buddha of that age hands the poor man his own bowl; the king offers money for it and is refused; the Buddha enters the low house without bowing, and afterward jewels rain down until the family has to carry the children outside. Reborn ages later to a merchant's daughter who craves to feed the monks redfish, the child is named Paṇḍita, "the Wise," and at seven becomes a novice under Sāriputta. On his eighth day, walking to the village, he sees irrigators

leading water, fletchers straightening arrows over a fire and carpenters shaping wheels, asks whether these things have minds, and turns back to master his own. Sakka sets guards, the sun and moon stand still, and the Buddha himself keeps watch at the door, delaying Sāriputta with four questions about food so that the boy reaches awakening before his meal arrives. Read the full commentary story.

Bronzeville, Chicago, Illinois

Bronzeville, 1952

Almost half of the Black Mississippians who left the state in the first decades of the Great Migration went to Chicago, many of them straight north by train, and in the second wave, from 1940 to 1960, the city's Black population nearly tripled, from 278,000 to 813,000. Hemmed in by white neighborhoods and industrial districts, they crowded into the South Side's Black Belt, where Bronzeville grew its own businesses, churches, insurance companies and newspapers. Forty-Seventh Street was its main stem; the 3,000-seat Regal Theater stood at 4719 South Parkway, the street later renamed for Martin Luther King Jr. From the Mississippi Gulf Coast, the old Gulf and Ship Island Railroad ran from Gulfport north to Jackson, and after 1925 it belonged to the Illinois Central, the line most Mississippians rode to Chicago.

Migrants brought their churches with them, many of them small congregations meeting in rented storefronts, and some kept the old practices of the rural South, including the mourners' bench, where seekers knelt or sat until they "came through" to conversion. The summer of 1952 was the worst polio season in American history, with about 58,000 cases nationwide, and parents across the country kept their children out of public swimming pools (Oak Park River Forest Museum).

After the story of the novice Paṇḍita from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 80). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

6.6

Zio Nino

Sta come torre ferma, che non crolla
già mai la cima per soffiar di venti.
— Dante, Purgatorio V, 14–15

Me l'hanno contata così, in the North End.

I. The Banker

Barre, Vermont · January 1910

Nino Vanelli stood four feet high in his boots, and he had cut stone for forty-four of his fifty-eight years. He was from Torano, above Carrara, where a boy went up to the marble as soon as he could carry water. He had left in the winter of 1894, when the soldiers came into the Lunigiana and a man who was known to hold the Idea did well to be on a ship. In Barre he carved what the big-handed men could not get their chisels into: the inside of a lily, the eyelids of an angel, the ivy that goes around a name. He worked at his banker standing on a plank laid across two soap boxes, and when the plank was not there he did not work, so the first thing the apprentices learned in Alexander Rennie's shed was where to hide it.

They learned the rest quickly. At the noon whistle there was half an hour, and bread and cheese do not take a boy of seventeen half an hour. So two of them would lift him off his box by the bib of his apron and stand him on a rough die block too high to get down from. One would take him by the forelock and tip his face up to the skylight. One would pinch his nose shut with a thumb and finger gray with dust and hold it until he had to open his mouth. They flicked his ears. They were not

cruel boys. They did it as they would have done it to a little brother or a cat, and the men at the other bankers mostly watched and chewed.

Then came the question, which was the point of it, and which even the Aberdeen boys had learned to say in Italian.

Zio. Zio Nino. Aren't you tired of the Idea yet? You still like it?

That winter they had a reason to ask. The sheds had been shut for three months the year before, four thousand men locked out, over the surfacing machine they called the bumper and the dust that it threw. The men had gone back on a promise that the bumper would be used less while the owners thought about ventilation. Aldo Bossi, who was from Viggiù and seventeen and the quickest of them with his hands, had eaten polenta for ninety days and was willing to say what he thought it had bought. And still on Saturday at noon the little man went from banker to banker with the *Cronaca* under his arm, five cents, and on the nights there was a speaker he sat in the front row at the Labor Hall on Granite Street with his feet a hand above the floor.

You still like it, Zio?

He never answered and he never pulled away. He stood on the block with his nose in a boy's fingers and waited, as a man at a crossing waits for the cars to go by. When they were done he said *The plank,* and one of them fetched it, and he got down backward as from a ladder, and found his place in the lily.

II. The Table

The Sora Argia's kitchen, North End · that night

Eleven men boarded with Argia Tonelli, and Nino had been one of them for fifteen years. She was Carrarese herself, from the town. Her husband had carved for the Rennies until the spring of 1905, when he died of the stonecutters' consumption in the back bedroom at forty-one. Since then she had kept the house, three meals and a bed and a nail for your coat. She also sold red wine by the glass at the kitchen table, a thing that the city of Barre both knew and did not know.

Nino ate early and went up. The others sat on over the wine, and that night they got to talking about him.

Did you see them today? The Bossi kid had him by the nose a full minute. I counted.

And nothing. He doesn't so much as go red.

He's used to it. Fifty years of being that size, you get used to it.

Nobody gets used to it. I'd have put a point through that boy's hand.

Then he's simple.

You carve one of his lilies and tell me he's simple.

Somebody brought up the other thing, which they understood no better. Two summers back a man had come up from Albany to see the monument for his wife. He had stood in front of the finished angel with his hat off, called Nino *maestro* before the whole shed, and laid a five-dollar gold piece on the stone by his mallet. Rennie had raised him a quarter a day on the spot. And Nino had looked at the gold piece and at the Albany man with the face he had worn that noon on the die block, and said *The plank,* because in making room somebody had moved it.

The Sora Argia came in from the stove with the pot against her hip.

What are you all talking about?

They told her. She set the pot down and filled the nearest bowl before she said anything.

Yes, she said. *That is how it is with him. You can pull his ears, he has ears. But what those boys are feeling around for, the thing you take hold of in a man to make him come along, he hasn't got that anymore. He put it down somewhere. The Albany gentleman couldn't find it either.*

She wiped her hands on her apron and looked around the table at eleven stonecutters.

You cut into that hill every day of your lives and you have to ask me? When the wind blows, what does the hill do?

Then she said the lines. She had them from her father, who could not read, and who had said them going up to the quarry in the dark with a coil of rope on his shoulder.

Vien dietro a me, e lascia dir le genti:
sta come torre ferma, che non crolla
già mai la cima per soffiar di venti.

Come after me, and to their babblings leave
The crowd. Be as a tower, that, firmly set,
Shakes not its top for any blast that blows!

— Dante, Purgatorio V, 13–15; tr. H. F. Cary (1814)

Praise is wind too, she said. *Eat.*

One of the men said, low, what the whole house had said for years and nobody had ever said to her. Every cutter in Barre coughed gray into his handkerchief by the time he was forty. Nino's handkerchief, when she boiled the wash on Monday, came out of his pocket as white as it went in.

She did not say it was so and she did not say it was not. She went back to the stove.

III. The Doors

Rennie's shed · the next noon

IT WAS FOUR BELOW ZERO AT THE WHISTLE, WITH THE WIND coming down off Millstone Hill. Aldo Bossi and the other boy had Nino up on the die block. Aldo had his thumb and finger on the old man's nose and was asking him whether he still liked it, when the yard gang rolled back the big doors at the end of the shed to bring in a block on the flat-car.

The wind came through the shed from one end to the other. It took the dust off every ledge and beam and banker, sixteen years of it, and for the length of a breath no man in the place could see the man beside him. Caps went. The drawings went off the wall. Aldo let go to cover his own face.

When the doors were shut and it had settled, the block sat on its car where the engine had left it, eighteen tons, gray, with frost on the upper face. Nino Vanelli stood on the die block with his hands at his sides and dust in his eyebrows. He had not put a hand up.

The plank, he said.
Aldo got it.

Background

The verse

> *As a solid rock is not shaken by the wind, wise people falter not amidst blame and praise.*
>
> Dhammapada 81, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is only a few lines long. The elder Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya was a dwarf, and novices and unawakened monks used to pull his hair and tweak his ears and nose, asking, "Uncle, you tire not of the Dispensation? You take delight in it?" He showed no resentment. The monks talked it over in the hall; the Buddha came in, asked what they were discussing, and said that those who have rid themselves of the pollutants are unmoved, like solid rock. Read the full commentary story, or the short discourse on Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya in the Udāna. The Sora Argia's lines are Virgil's, spoken to Dante when he slows on the mountain to hear what the shades are whispering about him.

Barre, Vermont

Barre, 1910

Barre grew from about two thousand people in 1880 to more than ten thousand in 1910 on gray granite, most of it cut into cemetery monuments. The carvers were largely northern Italians, many of them from the marble towns around Carrara, the cradle of Italian anarchism, which was put under a state of siege after the Lunigiana revolt of January 1894. In Barre they built the Labor Hall on Granite Street in 1900, and from 1903 to 1912 the anarchist weekly *Cronaca Sovversiva* was published in the

town. Boardinghouses were commonly kept by carvers' widows, who gave a bed, a chair and three meals and often sold wine or grappa at the table.

Pneumatic tools came into the sheds in the 1890s, and the dust they raised from Barre granite, which is rich in silica, killed the men who breathed it. They called the disease stonecutters' tuberculosis; it was silicosis. In 1909 a dispute over a heavy surfacing tool called the bumper led the manufacturers to lock out about four thousand men for three months, and the men went back on an agreement to limit the bumper while ventilation was designed; the owners then looked for a lighter bumper instead. Dust-removal equipment did not become standard until the late 1930s. Many carvers cut their own stones, and they stand in Hope Cemetery. Nino Vanelli, the Sora Argia and the Rennie shed are invented.

After the story of the Elder Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 81). The original. Scripture from Dante's Purgatorio, in Italian and in the translation of H. F. Cary (1814). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.7

Kaneez's Mother

> *Verily in the remembrance of Allah do hearts find rest!*
> *— Qur'an 13:28*

Main ne yun suna hai, under the 7 train.

I. Malpure

Corona, Queens · May 1989

On the block nobody called her Zubaida. Since the day her daughter was born in Gujranwala twenty-three years before, she had been Kaneez ki Ammi, Kaneez's mother, and when she came to America in 1975 with her husband and the girl and two suitcases tied with rope, the name came with her, the way names do. Her husband drove a cab for eleven years and died of his heart in the front seat of it on the Grand Central Parkway. She kept the two-family house off Roosevelt Avenue that he had bought with the cab money, and rented the top floor to a family from Guayaquil, and sewed shalwar kameez for half the Pakistani brides in Jackson Heights at a machine in her front window, where she could see the street.

Her rule about the door came from her own mother. Nobody who knocked at it went away with empty hands. Not the Jehovah's Witnesses, not the boys selling candy for their basketball team, not the man who came around every month for the Con Edison meter. She would give them a samosa in a paper napkin or a cup of tea or an orange from the bowl. Kaneez had been embarrassed by it all through high school.

In February Ammi slipped on the ice on the front steps and broke her wrist, and Kaneez came home from Brooklyn to help her. Kaneez had been married two years by then, to a boy named Tariq whose parents had

a house in Brooklyn and who drove a cab, as her father had, out of the same garage in Long Island City. It was supposed to be two weeks. Then the cast came off, and the wrist was weak, and there were brides waiting for their clothes, and then it was Ramadan and you could not leave your mother alone in Ramadan, and then it was Eid, and somehow it was May.

After Eid Tariq called. *Enough. Come home.*

She can't go back to her in-laws empty-handed, Ammi said to him on the phone, *after three months. What will your mother say? Give me one day. I'll make malpure.* Tariq's mother was from Gujranwala too, and she was famous in two boroughs for loving malpure, and for complaining that nobody in America knew how to make them.

So on Monday morning Ammi made the batter the way her mother had: flour and milk and sugar and a little semolina, crushed fennel, cardamom, left to stand an hour. Then she fried them one by one in ghee in the big karahi, each one a lacy brown disc the size of a saucer, crisp at the edges and soft in the middle, and lifted them out and dipped them in syrup and laid them in rows on her best steel tray, and the smell went out through the screen door and down the block and under the El.

The doorbell rang.

It was five men in white. They wore long kurtas and loose trousers that stopped above the ankle and white caps, and four of them had beards. One was an old Guyanese man with a cane. One was a Bangladeshi boy who could not have been nineteen. They were a jama'at, a party of travelers, staying three days at the new masjid on the other side of Corona, the one that had been built from the ground up to be a masjid, the first in the city. Every afternoon they went out on gasht, door to door through the Muslim streets with a man from the neighborhood to show them the way, to invite the brothers to come and pray Maghrib with them.

Assalamu alaikum, Ammi-ji, said the young one. *Is there a man of the house, to come to the masjid tonight?*

There was no man of the house. But there was the tray.

Ammi stood in her doorway with her hand on the frame and the smell of the malpure coming out past her into the street, and the men in white standing on her steps in the heat, and she could no more have closed that

door on them than she could have flown. She went to the kitchen and wrapped the whole tray in a clean cloth and brought it out and put it in the young one's hands.

The jama'ats had a rule, which the old ones taught the young ones. You ask nobody for anything. You pay your own way and carry your own bedding and cook your own food. But if something is offered with an open hand, you take it, and you thank God for it, because to refuse a gift is to refuse the giver. So they took it. The old Guyanese man made a long dua on the steps for her and her house and her daughter, and they went off down the block under the El with the steel tray going ahead of them like a lantern.

Ammi, said Kaneez from the kitchen.

I'll make more tomorrow, said Ammi. *Call Tariq. Tell him Wednesday.*

II. Four Trays

Two weeks in May

On Wednesday she made them again. The batter, the hour, the ghee, the syrup, the rows on the tray. A second tray, her other good one, the one with the handles. The doorbell rang at half past four. It was a different jama'at, from Toronto this time, six men, staying the week, and their guide was the same young man from the neighborhood who had brought the first ones, and he looked at Ammi and at the tray in the kitchen behind her with a face that said he was very sorry and also that he had smelled it from the corner.

She gave it to them.

Tariq's mother called on Thursday and talked to Ammi for half an hour in a voice Kaneez could hear from across the room.

The next Monday it was four men from Chicago. The Friday after that it was a jama'at of students from Long Island, boys, with their caps on crooked, and one of them had a Walkman around his neck that he had forgotten to take off, and he put his hand over it when he saw Ammi looking. She gave each of them the whole tray. She could not help it. Each time she stood in the door and meant to say, *Brothers, I'm sorry, these*

are for my daughter's in-laws, and each time the smell went out past her into the street and the words did not come, and she went and wrapped the tray.

Kaneez did not say anything the fourth time. She stood in the kitchen doorway with her arms folded and watched the tray go down the steps.

On the first of June Tariq got on a plane to Lahore. Kaneez heard about it from her cousin in Flushing, who had heard it from his cousin in Brooklyn. He was going to marry his father's brother's daughter, a girl of nineteen from Gujranwala, whom the families had talked about for him before Kaneez, and he would bring her back to Brooklyn when the papers came through, and Kaneez could stay at her mother's, since she liked it there so much.

Kaneez put the phone down very carefully, as if it might break.

Those beards, she said. *Those beards ate my marriage.*

III. Roosevelt Avenue

June and July 1989

After that Kaneez went a little crazy, the block said, and the block was not wrong.

She cursed them in the street. Any man in a white kurta and a white cap, any party of them going by in a line on gasht, any single brother coming down the stairs from the 103rd Street station with his sleeping bag on his back, she would go to the edge of the sidewalk and let him have it in Punjabi, the kind of Punjabi her mother had never let her learn and she had learned anyway. She called them beggars and thieves. She called them crows. She said they went door to door eating other people's weddings. She said it so loud that the Colombian women at the bus stop turned around, and the man at the fruit stand stopped weighing, and the train went over and drowned her out, and she waited till it passed and said the rest.

The jama'ats got so they would not come down her street. The young man from the neighborhood who guided them on gasht would stop at the corner of Roosevelt and say, *Not this block, brothers. We'll go around,* and

they would go around, five or six men in white walking a long way out of their way in the July heat, and Kaneez would watch them from the front steps.

Ammi said nothing. She sewed in her window. Sometimes at night Kaneez could hear her in the kitchen, standing at the stove with nothing on it.

At the masjid the elders talked it over after Isha, as they talked over everything. *She is grieving,* said one. *She is shaming us in the street,* said another. *Somebody should talk to her,* said a third, and they all agreed, and nobody went, because none of them wanted to stand on that sidewalk and hear it.

Bhai Yusuf went.

IV. Bhai Yusuf

The house off Roosevelt Avenue · a morning in August

He was seventy-one years old. He had worked the A train as a conductor for twenty-nine years, from Inwood to Far Rockaway and back, and retired with a pension and a gold watch he gave to his grandson. He had taken his shahada in 1962 at the old mosque on State Street in Brooklyn, where the imam was a man from Grenada and the people praying were from Harlem and Yemen and Bengal and Trinidad, and since then he had been going out in the path of God with the jama'ats, three days a month and forty days a year, for longer than most of the brothers had been alive. He had been to Raiwind. He had been to Dewsbury and to Durban and to a mosque in a strip mall in Texas. His Urdu was terrible and he knew it, and the young men from Lahore loved him for it. They called him Bhai Yusuf, Brother Yusuf, or Chacha, uncle, and the Bangladeshi boys called him Nana.

He did not say much. When he did, it was short.

He rang the bell at nine in the morning and Ammi opened the door and knew him, everybody knew him, and put her hand to her chest. Then she brought him in and sat him at the kitchen table in her husband's chair, and because there was no question of anything else she made him

breakfast: parathas fried in ghee, an omelette with green chilies and onion, tea boiled with milk and sugar and cardamom in the pan. He ate all of it slowly and said *alhamdulillah* at the end and wiped his mustache with the napkin.

Where is Kaneez?

Chacha-ji, she saw you from the window, said Ammi. *She is in the back room. She is crying.*

Why is she crying?

Because of what she has been saying to the brothers in the street. All summer. She saw you come up the steps and she knew why you came.

He nodded. He sat a while. A train went over on the El at the end of the block and the glasses on the shelf rattled and went still.

Ask her to come, he said.

Kaneez came out after a long time with her dupatta pulled down over her forehead and her eyes red and stood by the refrigerator, and would not sit, and would not look at him. So Ammi told it. She told it all, the malpure and the trays, the four jama'ats, Tariq's mother on the phone, the plane to Lahore, the girl of nineteen, all of it, standing by her own stove.

Bhai Yusuf listened to the whole thing. Then he turned to Ammi.

Sister. Those trays. Did the brothers take them from you? Or did you give them?

I gave them, Chacha-ji.

The brothers came to your door to invite people to the prayer. You put a tray in their hands. They said thank you and made dua for your house. What did they do wrong?

Ammi was quiet a moment. Then she said, *Nothing. They did nothing wrong. It was me.*

He turned to Kaneez by the refrigerator.

Daughter. You heard her. The brothers came to the door, and your mother gave, and they took what she gave them. What did they do wrong?

Kaneez opened her mouth to say it, the thing she had been saying all summer on Roosevelt Avenue, and it was not there. She looked for it and it was gone. She stood by the refrigerator with her hands open.

Nothing, she said. *They did nothing. It was me.*

Then she began to cry again, differently, and came and sat down at the table across from him, and asked him to forgive her, and to ask the brothers to forgive her, every one. He said that he forgave her and that they would. Then he told her a few things, not many. He said what her mother had done was the thing the Book praises, and he said it from the Book in English, in his conductor's voice, the voice that had called out the stations from 207th Street to the Rockaways.

> *And feed with food the needy wretch, the orphan and the prisoner, for love of Him, (Saying): We feed you, for the sake of Allah only. We wish for no reward nor thanks from you;*
>
> *— Qur'an 76:8–9*

Your mother fed travelers for love of Him, he said. *Four times. It cost her everything she had in the kitchen and her daughter's marriage. And she didn't want thanks. They gave her a dua on the steps and went off down the street. That's the whole story. Nobody in it did anything wrong except the one who threw a marriage away for a tray of sweets, and he's in Lahore.*

Kaneez laughed, in the middle of crying, before she could stop herself.

He talked a little more. About what a person keeps and what a person doesn't. About the three things that go on working for you after you are gone, which are what you gave away, and what you taught, and a child who prays for you, and nothing else, not a house, not a husband. Ordinary things. She had heard them all before, in the mosque and from her father, a hundred times. But a train went over at the end of the block, and the glasses on the shelf rattled, and then they stopped, and she sat there and felt herself go still the way the glasses did. All the way down. It was like looking into water that has been stirred up all summer and has finally settled, and seeing, for the first time, that it goes much deeper than you thought, and that it is clear all the way to the bottom.

Bhai Yusuf saw it. He did not say anything about it. He finished his tea and stood up and thanked Ammi for the breakfast, and went out and down the steps.

V. Chaudhry Sahib

Seventy-fourth Street, Jackson Heights · the same morning

He walked back toward the express stop under the El, the long way, because it was a fine morning and he liked to walk, and so he went past the office of Chaudhry Sahib.

Everybody knew Chaudhry Sahib. He had come in 1968 with a degree in engineering that nobody in New York would honor, and driven a cab, and bought a medallion, and then another, and now he owned forty of them and a travel agency on Seventy-fourth Street that sold more tickets to Karachi and Lahore than any other in the city, and two buildings, and a share of a sweet shop, and he paid for half of everything at the masjid and did not let anybody forget it. He was sitting in his office window doing the accounts when Bhai Yusuf went by, and he said to his nephew, *Is that Bhai Yusuf? Go and tell him I'm coming out.*

He came out onto the sidewalk in his shirtsleeves and embraced the old man and kissed his hand.

Chacha-ji. Where are you coming from so early?

From the house of Kaneez's mother, in Corona.

Kaneez? The one who curses the jama'ats on Roosevelt Avenue? What were you doing there?

I heard she was cursing the brothers. So I went.

And? Did you stop her?

She stopped, said Bhai Yusuf. *She's rich now. Richer than you. She has the kind of wealth nobody can take from her.*

Chaudhry Sahib looked at him a long time, there on the sidewalk under the El, with the people going around them. He was a proud man and not a fool.

All right, he said. *You made her rich in what can't be taken. I'll make her rich in what can.*

That Friday he sent his own car, the long grey Lincoln, to the house off Roosevelt Avenue for Kaneez and her mother. He had his wife dress Kaneez in a red and gold suit from the best shop on Seventy-fourth Street and put his own mother's gold bangles on her wrists, and he brought her

into the hall under the masjid after Jumu'ah, in front of everybody, and declared her his daughter. His munh-boli beti, his daughter by his own word, the eldest, with everything that went with it. Then he said, in front of everybody, *If there is a man here who thinks he can keep my daughter, let him come and talk to me.*

Tariq signed the papers from Lahore within the month. Chaudhry Sahib's lawyer saw to that.

The man who came to talk to him was Rana Sahib, a widower of forty with grown sons, who owned the halal meat wholesaler in Woodside and the garage in Long Island City and a piece of most other things in Queens that had a Pakistani name on them, and sat on every committee, and had a hand in everything. He married Kaneez in October. On the night of the wedding he gave her the keys to the big house in Fresh Meadows, with its two kitchens, and the checkbook, and said, *Do whatever good you like with it. I won't ask.*

VI. Four Doors

Fresh Meadows · 1990

SHE DID WHATEVER GOOD SHE LIKED.

She hired two cooks from Lahore and kept both kitchens going from Fajr to Isha. She paid four boys from the neighborhood, students, five dollars a day each, to stand at the doors of four masjids, in Corona and Jackson Heights and Astoria and Flushing, and ask every jama'at that came through whether they had eaten, and if they had not, to bring them to her house. Five men, ten men, twenty. Brothers from Leicester and Johannesburg and Trinidad and Dhaka, sleeping bags on their backs, sitting on the floor of her living room on white sheets she had spread over the carpet, eating biryani and nihari and her mother's malpure, and the food went out of her door and down the walk and onto the sidewalk in foil trays for anybody passing, like a river that had come up over its banks.

And it was never enough. That was the thing she said to the cooks, and to Rana Sahib, and to her mother, who had moved in with them and sat at

a sewing machine in the front window where she could see the street. *There aren't enough of them. I can't find enough of them.* She sent the boys out again. She called the masjid in Corona and asked when the next jama'at was coming from Toronto.

At the masjid the brothers talked it over after Isha, as they talked over everything.

Last summer four jama'ats ate her mother's trays and she cursed the whole lot of us in the street. We had to walk around her block. Now she can't find enough of us. Chacha went to her house one time and ate breakfast.

Bhai Yusuf was sitting against the back wall with his legs out in front of him and his cane across his lap.

It's not the first time, he said. They all turned around. *Not the first time those four got her into trouble. Not the first time I got her out.*

So they asked him, and he told them.

• • •

When he was twenty-two, he said, before the army, he swept the floor for an old diamond cutter on Forty-seventh Street, a Jewish man just over from Antwerp, in a room four flights up with a north window. And in the wall of that room there lived a mouse. She was an old mouse, and she had come with the building, and her people had been rich once, and she was sitting on what was left of it somewhere behind the plaster, all by herself. One day she came out across the floor with a nickel in her mouth and put it down by his broom.

What's this, Mother? he said.

Buy yourself something, said the mouse. *And buy me a little meat.*

So he went down to the deli on Sixth Avenue and bought her a slice of pastrami, and every day after that she brought him a nickel and he brought her a slice, and they were friends. Then one day a cat from the alley caught her. *Don't eat me,* said the mouse. *Are you hungry just today, or every day? Every day,* said the cat. *Then let me go, and I'll feed you every day.* So she gave the cat half her pastrami. Then a second cat caught her, and a third, and a fourth, and by the end she was cutting one slice of pastrami five ways and she was nothing but fur and bones.

He saw it, and asked her, and she told him. *Why didn't you say so?* he said. The diamond cutter had a block of rock crystal on the windowsill, big as a loaf of bread, that he used to hold the door. Bhai Yusuf borrowed the old man's tools one night and hollowed it out and put the mouse inside. *Now you stay in there,* he said, *and when they come, you tell them about themselves.*

The first cat came. *Where's my meat? Meat?* said the mouse. *Go home and eat your kittens.* And the cat was so mad he jumped at her, and he never saw the crystal, and he hit it so hard he never got up. And the same with the second cat, and the third, and the fourth. After that the mouse brought him two nickels a day, and then three, and by the end she had given him the whole fortune out of the wall a nickel at a time, and they were friends until she died.

The young brothers were laughing by then, and the old ones were shaking their heads.

Those four cats, said Bhai Yusuf, *were those four jama'ats. That mouse was Kaneez. Cursing at the whole world from inside a glass, and nothing could touch her. And she was right not to let anybody in. What else could she do?* He shifted his cane on his lap. *Only now there's no glass. Now she's out in the open, and she's gone still all the way down, like a pond in the morning. You can see right to the bottom. That's what it looks like when a person has heard something and it took.*

> *Who have believed and whose hearts have rest in the remembrance of Allah. Verily in the remembrance of Allah do hearts find rest!*
>
> *— Qur'an 13:28*

And the boy who cut the crystal? said the young Bangladeshi, who had been on that first gasht a year and a half before and had carried the first tray. *Who was the boy, Nana?*

Bhai Yusuf only looked at him, and got up with his cane, and went to make wudu for the night prayer.

• • •

Every morning that summer, after Fajr, Kaneez walked from the house in Fresh Meadows to Meadow Lake in the park and stood on the path by the water before the joggers came. Nobody ever knew why. The lake lay flat and grey under the planes coming down into LaGuardia, without a ripple, holding the whole sky. When the sun came over the trees she walked home and tied on her apron and went into the kitchen, where her mother was already at the karahi, frying the first malpure of the day, one at a time, and laying them out in rows on the big steel tray for whoever came to the door.

Background

The verse

> *Wise people, after they have listened to the laws, become serene, like a deep, smooth, and still lake.*
>
> Dhammapada 82, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a married daughter named Känä has been staying at her mother's house. Four times her mother fries cakes for her to take back to her husband, and four times a monk on his alms round comes to the door and the mother gives the cakes away. The husband takes another wife. Känä blames the monks and abuses every one she sees, until they no longer dare walk down her street. The Buddha goes to the house and eats breakfast there. Känä hides and weeps. He asks the mother whether the monks took the cakes or were given them, and what blame then falls on them. Mother and daughter each say the monks did nothing wrong, and Känä is transformed. On his way home the Buddha passes the palace. When the king hears what has happened, he says that if the Buddha has made her rich in the wealth beyond the world, he will make her rich in this one. He adopts Känä as his eldest daughter and gives her in marriage to a great noble, and she feeds monks so generously that she cannot find enough of them. The Buddha then tells the Jätaka of a mouse squeezed by four cats, whom a stonecutter saves by hiding her in a hollow crystal. Read the full commentary story, or about the Jätaka tales. The sweet cakes in the story are close cousins of the malpua, a fried cake whose name and recipe go back to Vedic India and which Pakistani families still make for Ramadan.

Corona, Queens, New York

Queens, 1989

New York's Muslim community is old and mixed. In 1939 the Grenadian-born convert Shaikh Daoud Faisal founded the Islamic Mission of America in Brooklyn Heights, now known as the State Street Mosque. After immigration law changed in 1965, and especially in the 1980s, newcomers from Pakistan, Bangladesh, Guyana, Senegal, Egypt and elsewhere settled in the outer boroughs, in neighborhoods such as Jackson Heights. In 1983 Masjid al-Falah in Corona, Queens, opened as the city's first purpose-built mosque (Islam in New York City).

The Tablighi Jamaat was founded in 1926 by Muhammad Ilyas Kandhlawi in the Mewat region of British India. After Partition its Pakistani center grew up at Raiwind, near Lahore, and the movement has since spread to more than 150 countries, the United States among them. It is a lay movement that keeps out of politics. Members go out in small traveling parties, or jama'ats, ideally paying their own way, carrying their bedding and staying in mosques. Each day they make a *gasht* through the local neighborhood, with a local guide, inviting Muslims to the evening prayer. The movement asks its members to give one night a week, one weekend a month and forty days a year to this work.

After the story of the mother of Känä from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 82). The original. Scripture from *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran*, tr. Marmaduke Pickthall (1930). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

6.8

Struck Measure

A man that Fortune's buffets and rewards
Hast ta'en with equal thanks.
— Hamlet, III.ii

This is how it's told, at the scales along the Crescent Cutoff.

I. The Padlock

Crescent Lake Junction, Oregon · September 1993

The man who invited them was named Vern, and he bought mushrooms. The November before, down in the tanoak country near the California line, he had weighed old Mrs. Saelee's baskets five nights running and had not found a mushroom in them with a torn veil or a knife mark. On the fifth night he came around the scale and spoke to her grandson, because the old woman had no English.

Tell her next fall I'll be up in the pine. Crescent Lake Junction, on the Cutoff road, a plywood shed with my name on it. Tell her to bring her people and camp behind me. There's a water tank. I'll have propane, and rice on my account at the store. I pay cash at the scale every night. Tell her it's her crew I want.

Kao told her. She looked at the man for a while, and said they would come.

Fahm Koy Saelee was seventy that year. She had been born in the hills above Muang Sing, in the north of Laos, and had walked out of that country in 1975 with a grandchild tied on her back. She buried her husband in a refugee camp in the north of Thailand and came at last to Redding, California, where the summers ran to a hundred and ten degrees and there was nothing anyone could think of for her to do. In the woods it was different. She carried a white bucket and a peeled stick and she nev-

er hurried, and where she stopped and touched the stick to the ground there was a mushroom under it.

Twelve of them picked. There was her daughter Meuy and Meuy's husband, and Kao, who was nineteen and did the talking. There was her nephew San, who had been a soldier at fifteen and could bring two full buckets up out of a canyon at a trot. There were two widows from her street in Redding, and Uncle Lu with his bad hip, and the rest were cousins.

Then there were the boys. Five of them, cousins' sons, nineteen and twenty years old, had heard there was money lying on the ground in Oregon and had come up behind the trucks in a Honda with a sleeping bag apiece. They had no eye for it. They could walk straight across a patch and never know. Nobody had asked them along and nobody sent them home. They ate what was left in the pot after the pickers had eaten. That was the arrangement, and no one had ever needed to say it.

They drove up the week after Labor Day, four hours from Redding, and found the shed where he had said it would be. VERN, it said in red paint, MATSUTAKE, CASH. There was a padlock on the door. The water tank was dry. The man at the store had never heard of any account.

Vern was in British Columbia. It had rained in August in the country north of Terrace, and the pine mushrooms had come up there by the ton, and every buyer who could get himself across the line was standing in that rain with a roll of bills, bidding against every other. He bought until two in the morning and was on the road again at five. He hadn't decided anything about the people he had asked to the junction. They weren't in his head. From Labor Day until the snow he did not think of them one time.

At the junction it did not rain. The ground there is pumice, three and four feet of it, blown out of the mountain that left Crater Lake, and lodgepole pine stands on it as close as fence pickets. In a right year the duff under those trees holds the wet, and the mushrooms push it up from below in little cracked domes that a picker learns to see from ten yards off. That September the duff was dry down to the pumice, and a boot went into it like flour. The buyers along the Cutoff sat in lawn chairs be-

side their scales. In two weeks the twelve of them brought in nine pounds, and the money went for permits and gasoline. After that there was nothing. Meuy went from shed to shed asking for rice against the season, and the buyers, who were Lao and Mien and white and were eating out of cans themselves, turned up their hands. Other crews folded their tarps and left. The rice sack went slack, and then it lay flat.

II. A Struck Measure

October

Across the Cutoff from the shed stood a pole corral, and in the first week of October a man named Hank Teal backed a stock truck up to it and let down nine horses and two mules. He packed elk hunters into the Diamond Peak country every fall, and he came early to shoe and to let the string get its wind at that height. He was past sixty and he minded his own business. He minded it for four days. He watched the smoke behind the padlocked shed and he watched what came out of the woods in the white buckets at evening, and on the fifth morning he walked across the road with a fifty-pound sack on his shoulder and an aluminum feed scoop in his hand.

It's barley. Steam-rolled. It's clean, it's what they get. He tipped his head back toward the corral. *I can't do a lot. I've got eleven head to carry through November and I bought close. I can do a scoop apiece, every day.*

He showed Kao what he meant by it. He drove the scoop into the sack and brought it up heaped, and drew the flat of his hand across the top so that what stood above the rim fell back. *Struck measure, my granddad called that. Not heaped and not scant.* He did it seventeen times into the rice pot, once for each person in the camp, the boys included, and went back over the road to his horses.

So that fall they ate horse feed. Rolled barley is the whole kernel, steamed until it is soft and run between rollers until it is flat as a thumbnail, so that a horse gets the good of it. The women pounded it in a bucket with the butt of a peeled pole and boiled it a long time with salt. It made a gray porridge that tasted the way a feed store smells. The old wo-

man ate hers first, where all of them could watch her do it. Then the pickers ate. Then the boys ate what was left and scraped the pot, and in those weeks the boys were as quiet as anyone had ever known them. They sat on the tailgate of the Honda with their hands between their knees. They were in their sleeping bags by dark.

Every morning Hank Teal came over with the sack. After the first week she met him at the edge of the road with the pot, and he gave her the scoop, and she struck the seventeen measures herself with the side of her hand. He noticed she was harder on a heap than he was.

It was San who couldn't bear it. He came to her at the fire one night with a potato rake he had found behind the store.

There's a flat beyond the cinder pit, a mile of it. They're in there. They're six inches down where the damp is, buttons, hundreds, and they can't lift the duff. Give me two nights and a headlamp. I'll turn that whole flat over. Nobody will see.

No.

Grandmother. There is money under the ground and your people are eating what horses eat.

It's alive under there, she said. *All one body, the length of that flat. Turn it over and nothing comes up in that place again while Kao is living.*

He put the rake down. A week later he tried the other way. Kao had been on the pay phone at the store, and the word was all Canada. *Then let me take the truck north. It's raining there and they're paying what nobody ever paid. I'll take everyone who can pick.*

She looked across the fire at the two widows, and at Uncle Lu with his leg laid out straight on a feed sack.

And those?

The truck holds six.

No, she said, and he did not ask again.

What the people who stayed at the junction that fall remembered afterward was that nobody in the camp behind Vern's shed complained. They were up at five. They walked the flats in a line with their sticks, and came back with the buckets light, and ate their measure of barley, and slept. At night nobody talked about pork, or about what the money would

buy when it came. Hank Teal said he had fed that barley to horses that made more remarks about it.

III. The Jackets

The last week of October

Rain came on the twenty-third. Snow came down to the road four days behind it, and that was the season in the pine. They had picked forty pounds between the one and the other.

Vern came back with the snow. He had made more in eight weeks than in the six years before, and he drove in at dusk in a different truck to fetch his scale. He saw the tarps behind the shed. Then he saw the feed sacks, nine of them, folded square and weighted with a rock, and he stood and read the printing on the top one.

She came out to him herself, with Kao beside her. She hadn't come about the water tank or the account at the store. She came because a person does not leave a man's place without telling him.

She says we go tomorrow. She says thank you for the ground to camp on.

Vern had been an actor once and had a voice that could reach the back of a house, and for a while he couldn't find any of it. *I never thought about you,* he said finally. *Tell her that. It isn't that I thought of it and stayed away. I never once thought of it.*

Kao told her. She nodded, the way she nodded when he told her the price.

He was gone three hours. He came back from La Pine with a hundred pounds of rice and two cases of chickens, and from a logging supply on the highway he brought seventeen rain jackets, the heavy rubber kind, dark green, in whatever sizes they'd had. He cooked the chickens himself over their fire and did not sit down while they ate. Afterward he went around the circle with the jackets, and when he got to the old woman he held hers open behind her, and she put her arms into it.

Ask her how she stood it. Eight weeks. I'd have burned the shed.

Kao asked. *She says there wasn't anything to stand. It was a dry year.*

I'm in Cave Junction through December. The old Texaco on the Redwood Highway. Tell her I'll have the lights on.

She says we go there anyway.

In the morning she carried the scoop across the road, washed. Hank Teal was graining his string. He looked at it and at her and went on down the line of feed pans. *I've got another one,* he said.

IV. The Forks

Cave Junction, Oregon · November

In the Illinois Valley it had been raining for three weeks. The mushrooms there come up under tanoak and madrone, on slopes a goat would think about, and they were lifting the wet leaves everywhere a person looked. A bucket was full by ten in the morning. That was also the fall the price went where it had never been. The junction had failed, and people said the crop in Japan had failed, and there were not enough matsutake in the world. It was told for years afterward that on one night that season number-one buttons went for six hundred dollars a pound, for about two hours, at a scale in the woods. Nothing like that came to the Illinois Valley. But Vern at the old Texaco paid more each night than he had the night before, and the crew was making in a day what a good week had made them other years. On the second Saturday the relatives drove up from Redding with a pig in the bed of a pickup, and killed it by the river, and there was food for sixty people.

The boys had money too. They had learned at last to see a hump under madrone leaves, or else they walked behind the pickers and took what had been missed, and at those prices what had been missed was wages. They still ate at the old woman's pot, after the others, and what was left in the pot now was pork. They slept until ten. When they got up they went down to the gravel bar where the two forks of the Illinois come together, and after that anybody in Cave Junction could have told you where they were. They hollered. They jumped off the rock into the green hole in November. They wrestled on the gravel for twenty-dollar bills, and drove the Honda in circles with the doors open and the stereo turned

up, and bought a second car and drove that in circles. In town they were put out of the laundromat and the pizza place, and a deputy came out to the camp twice to talk to Kao about them.

The pickers talked about it at the fire. *Look at those five. At the junction they sat on that tailgate like boys at a funeral. Eight weeks on horse feed and not a sound out of them, and now look.* Then somebody said the other thing, which was that the old woman's camp was the same camp it had been. They were up at five. They were in the woods when it got light. Each night she measured the rice into the pot with Hank Teal's scoop, one for each of them, and struck it level with the side of her hand, and she was asleep by eight.

She came to the fire and asked what the talk was, and they told her. Vern was there. He had taken to walking down from the Texaco once he'd closed his ticket book, and he stood at the edge of the light, and Kao put things into English for him when he remembered to.

She said:

When I was a girl the Haw came through our village in the dry season, Chinese from Yunnan with forty mules, carrying salt and iron pots. One year the headman opened a jar of the good liquor for the caravan master, the first of the run. The caravan master wanted us to see what kind of man he was. He poured a bowl of it down every mule he had. Forty mules drank the best liquor in that district and stood in the pen all night with their eyes half shut. You wouldn't have known a mule was there.

My father had two ponies. They had never carried anything farther than our field. The boys of the village took the mash from the bottom of the jar and poured water over it and wrung it through a cloth, and gave the ponies that. It was dishwater. There wasn't liquor enough in it to burn.

Those ponies screamed until morning. They kicked the pen flat. When it got light one of them was standing on the roof of the pig house.

The pickers laughed. Down on the bar the stereo was going.

Same ponies as always, she said. *A year is dry or it's wet. It's the same ground under it. You get up and look at the ground.*

Kao gave that to Vern as well as he could. Vern didn't say anything for some time. Then he spoke, toward the fire, in the voice he had not been

able to find at the junction, and all of them looked up at the sound of it though only Kao had any of the words.

> *For thou hast been*
> *As one, in suffering all, that suffers nothing,*
> *A man that Fortune's buffets and rewards*
> *Hast ta'en with equal thanks. And blessed are those*
> *Whose blood and judgement are so well co-mingled*
> *That they are not a pipe for Fortune's finger*
> *To sound what stop she please.*
>
> *— Hamlet, III.ii*

What does he say?

Kao thought about it. *He says it's from an old play. There's a man in it who gets hit and gets paid, and says thank you the same for both. He says that's you.*

She looked at Vern for a while, as she had the first time.

Tell him to sit down, she said.

He sat, and Meuy filled a bowl and handed it across to him.

• • •

The scoop went back to Redding in the rice sack. It is aluminum and holds a quart, and it has a dent in one side where a mule stood on it before any of this happened. It has measured rice in that family in falls when number ones brought sixty dollars and in falls when they brought six. Whoever has it in her hand draws the side of the hand across the top.

Background

The verse

> *Good people walk on whatever befall, the good do not prattle, longing for pleasure; whether touched by happiness or sorrow wise people never appear elated or depressed.*
>
> Dhammapada 83, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha and five hundred monks spend a rainy season at Verañjā as guests of a brahmin who, "under the spell of Māra," does not think of them for a single day. There is a famine, and the monks live on measures of steamed grain given them by horse-dealers. Mahā Moggallāna offers to turn the earth over so they can eat what lies beneath it, or to take them north to Uttarakuru, and is refused both times (in the Vinaya's telling the Buddha asks what would become of the creatures that live in the ground). Nobody complains. At the end of the season the Buddha takes formal leave of the brahmin, who honors him at last. Back at Jetavana, where food is plentiful, five hundred hangers-on who live on the monks' leftovers and were quiet all through the famine go shouting and wrestling on the riverbank. The Buddha tells of the donkeys who got drunk on the strained washings of the wine that war-horses had drunk and stood quiet on. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Moggallāna.

Crescent Lake Junction, Oregon

The Oregon Cascades, *1993*

Matsutake, the pine mushroom, cannot be farmed. When Japan's own woods stopped producing enough of it, exporters turned to the Pacific Northwest, and from the late 1980s a circuit of commercial pickers followed the fruiting from British Columbia down to northern California. Many were Cambodian, Lao, Hmong and Iu Mien refugees. The country around Crescent Lake and Chemult, where lodgepole pine grows on deep pumice from the eruption of Mount Mazama, became the center of the trade, with independent buyers weighing mushrooms for cash at roadside sheds every evening. The price could move by many dollars in a night, and by the mid-1990s it had been as high as six hundred dollars a pound. Raking the forest floor to get at buried buttons was the practice everyone argued about. A study begun near Diamond Lake in 1994 found that removing the litter layer and not replacing it was "strongly detrimental" to later fruiting, while careful picking did no harm. The anthropologist Anna Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* describes these camps closely.

The Iu Mien are a highland people of southern China and northern Laos. Many Mien men fought on the American side in the war in Laos, and after 1975 whole villages crossed into refugee camps in Thailand and were resettled, a few years later, in California and Oregon. Tsing writes that the Mien encampments in the matsutake woods were the nearest thing their elders had found in America to a village in upland Laos. Steam-rolled barley is ordinary horse feed. The dry fall, the buyer, the packer and the Saelee crew are invented.

After the story of the five hundred bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 83). The original. Verse from Shakespeare's *Hamlet*. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.9

Decay Heat

What should I do with that by which I do not become immortal?
— Brihadâranyaka Upanishad II.4.3

What I was told, on the back shift at Palisades.

I. The Advisor

Covert Township, Michigan · 1981

The job had not existed before the accident. After Three Mile Island the government decided that every nuclear control room in the country ought to have one person on shift with an engineering degree and nothing to do with his hands, somebody who would stand back from the boards when the alarms came in and think. They called him the shift technical advisor. At Palisades, on the Lake Michigan dunes below South Haven, one of the first was S. Ramanathan, thirty-three years old, late of Kumbakonam, Ann Arbor and the Bechtel Corporation, whom the operators called Ram.

He was good at it. The operators were Navy men and had expected to resent him, and found they didn't. He sat at a steel desk behind the horseshoe of panels and watched. He read the logs back three shifts before he took the watch. He never touched a switch. That was the rule of the job, and Marv Dykstra, the shift supervisor, said he had the look of a man who would have kept the rule if nobody had written it down. When he was on days he stopped on the way home at the state park beside the plant and walked down to the water, because the lake was to the west and the sun went into it. There he did what his father and his father's father had done at that hour on the steps of the great tank at Kumbakonam, with a little water in the hollow of his hand. Then he went home to his

wife. They had a brick ranch house on a street of maples in South Haven, a Buick, a savings account, and a company pension that grew every month whether he looked at it or not.

One evening in the fall of 1981 they were sitting over their coffee after supper, talking pleasantly about nothing much, and he told her.

Lalitha. I want to go. I want to take sannyasa.

She did not ask what he meant. She had grown up in Mylapore and she knew what the word asked of a man. He performs his own funeral. He breaks the thread he has worn since he was seven. After that he belongs to no house.

I am going to have a child, she said. *In February. Wait until the child is born.*

He had not known. He looked at her, and then he laughed out loud and got up and came around the table.

He waited.

II. The Second Asking

South Haven · 1983

THE BOY WAS BORN IN A SNOWSTORM OFF THE LAKE, AND THEY named him Shankar. By the next spring he was walking. He went from the couch to the coffee table and from the coffee table to his father's knee, and one evening in May, when he had got as far as the screen door on his own and stood slapping it with both hands, Ramanathan asked again.

He is walking.

He is one year old. Wait until he is a man. Let him finish school and find work. Then go, and I will pack the bag for you myself.

She meant it, and he saw that she did. He saw too that after the work there would be a wedding to wait for, and after the wedding a grandchild, and that she would mean it every time. He thought, It makes no difference whether she says yes. Nobody can let another person out.

That summer the company offered to put him in the license class, which was the road to shift supervisor and from there to running the

place. He thanked them and said no. He paid off the house. He put the savings and the car in her name, and drove to the benefits office in Jackson and signed what there was to sign. On a Tuesday in September he stood his last back shift, read the logs over to his relief, and walked out through the gate with his lunch pail. He was on a plane out of Chicago that night. He had told her the date a month before, and she had not spoken to him since.

Marv Dykstra came to the house on the Thursday. He had spent eleven years on submarines and did not know what a person says in a kitchen. He stood in hers with his cap in his hand and told her what he did know.

He tripped the plant on you. That's what this is. The rods are in. That part takes about two seconds, and everybody thinks it's the end. The boy had hold of his trouser leg. *It isn't. You've still got six, seven percent of full power coming off that core with nothing splitting. That's your decay heat. An hour later it's a percent and a half. Next day, under half a percent. It comes down fast and then it comes down slow, and you and I won't live to see it get to nothing. At Three Mile Island the rods went in eight seconds after the trouble started. They lost the core two hours later, off the heat that was left. Nobody can fight it. All you do is keep water on it.*

She looked at him.

They're hiring a chemistry technician, he said. *You've got the degree. I'd put my name on it.*

III. Water

1983 *to* 2005

She took the job. She had a bachelor of science from Queen Mary's College in Madras that she had never expected to use, and for twenty-three years she drew samples of the water that ran through the reactor and told the control room what was in it. She was exact. People on the back shift said you could set the boron by her.

She kept the house. She kept it for the boy, who came off the school bus at ten to four. She kept it also for the man, though she would not have said that to anyone living. His steel coffee tumbler stayed on the

shelf where it had always stood, and she washed it when she washed the shelf.

When Shankar was four he asked where his father was, and she told him as much of the truth as a boy of four could carry, that Appa had gone to live beside the Ganges. Fifteen miles north of South Haven the Blue Star Highway runs through a crossroads with a store and a township hall, and the sign there says GANGES. Somebody liked the name a long time ago. There is a retreat among the orchards that the Vedanta swamis from Chicago have kept since 1971, and she drove up some Sundays for the talk and for the Upanishad class that old Visalam Mami gave afterward. The boy saw the sign from his car seat and sat up straight. Every time, until he was six or seven, he looked over the people on the lawn for a man who would know him.

Ramanathan was eight thousand miles east of that sign, at Uttarkashi, where the river is still called the Bhagirathi and comes down gray with rock flour between the hills. An old swami had a few rooms and a few students above the bathing steps. He asked the newcomer one thing, whether his wife had let him go, and when Ramanathan said she had not, the old man said, *Then you have brought her,* and gave him the room by the door. He studied grammar for three years before they let him near the texts. He ate once a day at the charity kitchen with the other sadhus. For a long time what he found when he sat down was a kitchen in Michigan and a small boy at a screen door. He sat with that the way he had been taught to sit with the panels, and kept his hands off it. In his seventh year he was given the ochre cloth and a name. Some time after that, the people who knew him there said, he was finished with it. He never said so himself. They said it of him because he had stopped being in any hurry, and because of how easily he had started to laugh.

Shankar grew up on the lake. He was a quiet boy and good with machinery, and at twenty he hired on at Palisades as an auxiliary operator. By the summer of 2005 he was in the license class his father had turned down. His mother had not asked it of him. She had not needed to.

IV. Ganges

Ganges, Michigan · August 2005

A letter came in June, the first in twenty-two years, in a hand she knew. The swamis in Chicago had invited a teacher from Uttarkashi to give the August classes at the retreat. He would be at Ganges three weeks. The letter asked for nothing.

She did not go. She told Shankar, and left the letter on the kitchen table, and on a Saturday he drove up the Blue Star Highway and turned in past the sign.

His father was sitting in a lawn chair under an apple tree with his head shaved, in an orange cloth, a smaller man than the one in the photograph. He looked up at Shankar the way the boy had once looked over the people on that lawn. Neither of them moved to touch the other. Shankar had driven up with one sentence ready, and he said it.

I couldn't talk yet. You left before I could say one thing to you.

Yes, his father said.

He said nothing after it. He waited for the rest, and there was a great deal of the rest, and it took most of an hour, and he did not put up a word against any of it.

Afterward they sat. His father asked what he did at the plant, and Shankar told him about the rounds and the readings and the license class, and the simulator in the training building where they ran the bad nights over and over.

And when nothing is wrong?

Then you watch. That's most of it. Forty numbers. If you're doing it right, nothing happens.

I was paid to do that for three years, his father said. *To sit behind the boards and watch, and keep my hands off. I was good at it. Nobody there could have told me the chair turns around.*

Turns around to what?

To whoever is doing the watching. Look for him the way you look at the forty numbers. Don't touch anything. See whether you find anybody.

Shankar looked at the grass. The August classes ran three weeks, and he drove up eleven times.

V. Background

South Haven · 2006 *and* 2007

In the spring he passed the license examination. In June he gave the company his notice and gave his mother the keys to his truck. She did not ask him to wait. She had asked that of somebody once. He went the way his father had gone.

She stayed one more winter. The house was paid for and the pension had vested long ago. In April the company sold the plant to a firm from Louisiana, and there was a new badge to be issued and a new benefits book to read, three hundred pages of it. She sat down with it at the kitchen table, with the steel tumbler on its shelf and the door of the boy's room shut, and got as far as the table of contents.

Both the ones I kept it for are gone, she said to Visalam Mami on the telephone that night. *What am I keeping?*

When a person leaves a nuclear plant for good, she goes into the whole-body counter before she turns in her badge. It is a shielded booth with a detector in it, and it looks through the body for anything the work has left there. She stood in it for two minutes on her last afternoon. The technician was a young woman she had trained.

You're clean, Mrs. Ramanathan. Twenty-three years. There's nothing in you but potassium.

Potassium?

Everybody's got that. If you're clean it's all this thing ever finds. It's background.

She signed the form and went out through the gate.

• • •

On the second Sunday of that September, when she had been six weeks in a house of women in ochre at Haridwar, the families stood on the lawn at Ganges after the class, holding their paper plates, and talked about the

Ramanathans, as they had been talking about them on and off for twenty-four years.

Think of it. The whole house. First he went, then the boy, and now she.

He was a great soul. He showed his son the road.

He was a selfish man who was lucky in his family.

Whatever he was, he got all three of them across. Which of us will manage that?

Visalam Mami was eighty-one. She had lectured in Sanskrit at Queen Mary's before most of them were born, and she still had her finger in the book. She said it first in Sanskrit. Then she said it in the English of the old Oxford volumes she had taught from in Madras.

> *Wishing for that world (for Brahman) only, mendicants leave their homes.*
>
> *Knowing this, the people of old did not wish for offspring. What shall we do with offspring, they said, we who have this Self and this world (of Brahman)? And they, having risen above the desire for sons, wealth, and new worlds, wander about as mendicants. For desire for sons is desire for wealth, and desire for wealth is desire for worlds. Both these are indeed desires only.*
>
> *— Brihadâranyaka Upanishad IV.4.22*

So you needn't count it up as something he got, she said. *He didn't go for the boy's sake. If he had, it would have been one more thing wanted. And he didn't go for his own. That is the part nobody believes.*

She shut the book on her finger and looked round for somewhere to put her plate.

• • •

The fuel that was in the core on the night Ramanathan stood his last watch came out at a later refueling and went under forty feet of water. It stayed there for years. In the nineties it was moved into a concrete cask on a pad in the dunes, with vents at the foot and vents at the top. Nobody

keeps water on it now. Air goes in below and comes out above a little warmer than it went in, and that is enough.

Background

The verse

> *If, whether for his own sake, or for the sake of others, a man wishes neither for a son, nor for wealth, nor for lordship, and if he does not wish for his own success by unfair means, then he is good, wise, and virtuous.*
>
> Dhammapada 84, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a householder of Sāvatthī who lives rightly tells his wife, in the middle of a pleasant conversation, that he wants to go forth. She asks him to wait until their child is born. When the child can walk he asks again, and she asks him to wait until the child is grown. He decides that her permission makes no difference, goes forth, and reaches the goal. Later he returns and teaches his son, who goes forth and reaches it too. His wife thinks, "Both of those for whom I desired to live the household life have gone forth," and follows them. When the monks praise him for the example he set his son, the Buddha answers that a wise person seeks success neither for his own sake nor for another's. Read the full commentary story. The triad of the verse (son, wealth, realm) is older than Buddhism. The B*ṛ*hadāra*ṇ*yaka Upanishad, quoted here in Max Müller's translation (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 15, 1884), names the same three desires. It also tells of the sage Yājñavalkya leaving home and of his wife Maitreyī, who refuses her share of his property with the question that stands at the head of this story.

Covert and South Haven, Michigan

Palisades and Ganges, 1981–2007

The Palisades plant stands in the dunes of Covert Township, Michigan, beside Van Buren State Park, and first ran at the end of 1971. On March 28, 1979, at Three Mile Island in Pennsylvania, the reactor shut itself down eight seconds into the trouble, and the core was half melted some hours later because the heat still coming off it was not carried away. One of the changes ordered afterward was the shift technical advisor, an engineer on every shift whose work was to assess, not to operate. Decay heat behaves as the shift supervisor says: about six or seven percent of full power at shutdown, about one and a half percent an hour later, under half a percent after a day. Spent fuel is kept under water for years before it can be stored in air-cooled casks. Workers leaving a plant are checked in a whole-body counter, which always finds the natural radioactive potassium present in every human body. Palisades was sold to Entergy, of New Orleans, in April 2007.

Ganges is a crossroads on the Blue Star Highway in Ganges Township, Allegan County. The Vivekananda Vedanta Society of Chicago, a branch of the Ramakrishna Order, established its retreat there in 1971. Indian engineers and their families, many of them South Indian Brahmins, came to the American Midwest in numbers after the immigration law changed in 1965. Sannyasa, the formal renunciation of household life, is by tradition the last of the four stages of a life, and whether a husband may take it without his wife's consent has been argued over for a very long time. The Ramanathans, the shift supervisor, the old swami at Uttarkashi and Visalam Mami are invented.

After the story of the Elder Dhammika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 84). The original. Scripture from the B*ri*hadâra*n*yaka Upanishad in F. Max Müller's translation (1884). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.10

Hands Full

But he who kisses the Joy as it flies
Lives in Eternity's sunrise.
— William Blake, "Eternity"

The way it got told on our block, at Mizzen and 210 degrees.

I. The Block

Black Rock City, Nevada · Friday, August 30, 2002

That year the theme was the Floating World, and the city was laid out like a chart. The dry lake was the sea. The Man stood on a lighthouse in the middle of it, and the streets that curved around him were named for the parts of a ship from bow to stern, Bowsprit and Forecastle and Mainmast and on back to Fantail, with the last street of all called Abyss. The cross streets were compass bearings. Five camps shared the block of Mizzen between 195 and 210 degrees. There was Camp Barnacle, from Fresno. There were some nurses from Reno who ran a foot-washing station, and six kids from Santa Cruz with a trampoline, and a camp that did nothing but mend zippers. And there were two brothers from Elko who had brought a smoker and a hundred pounds of brisket and had forgotten shade.

Nothing is bought or sold in that city but ice and coffee, so what a block has is what it gives away. On Friday the five camps put everything in together. There was the brothers' brisket and the nurses' rice, and forty pounds of peaches Dale Fenner had driven up from Fresno on ice. From two o'clock until the dust came they fed whoever walked down Mizzen, something over three hundred people, out of whatever bowl or cup or frisbee each one had along.

At half past four the dust came through, a brown wall out of the west, and for twenty minutes nobody could see the next tent. Then it rained. It rained cold for a quarter of an hour, and when it quit a rainbow stood over the lighthouse with both feet on the playa. The air was washed so clean that you could see the old beach lines on the mountains, where the lake had stood before it dried up.

One of the nurses said it, standing in the middle of the street with her goggles pushed up on her forehead. *Tonight's the night to go hear Bernadette.*

Everyone on Mizzen had heard of Bernadette. She was a woman past fifty who rebuilt bus transmissions in Oakland. Once a year she drove an old International flatbed across two miles of open playa to the far corner of the orange fence, which is as far from the city as a person is allowed to go, and played records. She played one set. It began when the sun went behind the Granite Range and it ended when the sun came up. People who knew said it was built to be heard straight through, the way a sermon is, and that the last half hour wasn't for anybody who hadn't stood through the ten and a half before it.

All of us, Dale said. He sold commercial refrigeration, and he was the nearest thing the block had to a mayor. *The whole street. We go out together and we stay till the sun's up. Nobody peels off.*

Forty-one people said they were in.

II. The Shore

Sunset to two

They rode out in one long string as the lamplighters were coming down the avenues, forty-one bicycles wound with glow wire, and the kid in front carried a plate of brisket and a thermos for her, wrapped in a towel.

The truck sat with its tail to the fence. Four speaker stacks stood strapped to the bed, and between them a plywood table held two turntables under a red work light. There was no banner and no sign. Along the side rail of the bed somebody had painted four lines in white

house paint, small, so that a person had to walk the length of the truck to read them, and in the dark nobody did. Bernadette took the plate, said *thank you, baby* to the kid who handed it up, and set it down by the generator. She had no microphone. In all the years she had come out, nobody had heard her say a word over those speakers.

The first record was already going. It was slow, slower than anything people dance to, with a kick drum in it like something asleep and breathing, and for most of an hour it hardly changed. The ones who had come to dance stood around waiting to be told what to do.

From the fence the city was a long low line of colored light. It looked the way a shore does from a boat. All along the front of it, on the Esplanade, a thousand smaller lights were going back and forth. They were bicycles, riding from the big sound camps at 60 degrees around to the big sound camps at 300 and back again, the whole night, looking for the best thing. You could stand at the truck and watch them. They didn't come any nearer and they didn't stop.

By eleven the pairs had begun to go. It was a clear cold night after the rain, and a set like that one puts people close together. A boy from the trampoline camp and one of the nurses went first, walking their bikes. Then two more went. Then it was a married couple from Barnacle who had not, as Dale happened to know, been getting along. Nobody announced anything. You looked around and there were fewer. By one o'clock fourteen of them were back in the tents.

III. The Fence

Two to sunrise

AT TWO A PICKUP WITH A PLYWOOD SHARK BUILT OVER IT came out of the dark with its own stereo going and parked forty feet off the corner of the flatbed. Dale walked over to explain. The man driving the shark explained back. It took an hour and ten minutes and one of the Rangers, and it pulled eight or nine of the block in on Dale's side. When the shark had finally backed off and gone, Dale found that he was shaking. He had not heard a note in over an hour. The thing playing in his

HEAD WAS EVERYTHING HE OUGHT TO HAVE SAID. HE STOOD another ten minutes with his jaw set, and then he got on his bicycle and rode for the city, composing it, and the ones who had been in the argument rode with him, still talking. A man from the zipper camp stayed half an hour longer to tell whoever stood near him that it had all been better in '98.

The ones left were too tired to quarrel and too tired to go. They had been on their feet since six that morning serving brisket. One at a time they sat down on the playa where they were, in their fur coats, and pulled their hats over their eyes, and told each other they could hear it fine from there. She was playing things by then that would have had them all on their feet at midnight. By four they lay around the truck on the cracked ground like seals on a beach, with the dust settling on them, and the bass went through them, and they slept.

At ten to six the sky behind the fence went gray, and then it went the color of the inside of a peach. Bernadette put on the last record. It was a white label she had found in 1993 in a milk crate, in a used record shop on Grand River Avenue in Detroit. Three people from Mizzen were standing up for it. There was a nurse named Trish, and the younger of the brothers from Elko, and a boy of nineteen from Santa Cruz who had come to Nevada to get as far from his father as his car would go. What they heard in that half hour, none of the three ever managed to tell the block. The brother from Elko said only that it had been one record. She had been playing one thing since sundown, he said, and he hadn't known it until the end.

IV. Mizzen and 210

Saturday morning

THE BLOCK CAME BACK TOGETHER AROUND THE COFFEE AT nine, under Barnacle's shade, and counted. It was three out of forty-one. The lovers were pleased with themselves until about ten. Dale was still giving his speech to the shark. The sleepers swore they had heard every bit of it, and one of them could hum some.

The flatbed came down Mizzen at the five miles an hour the city allows, with a tarp over the stacks. She stopped at 210 and handed down the plate and the thermos, washed.

How many of you all made it?

Three, Dale said. *We said the whole street.* He told her how it had gone and who went where. He didn't leave himself out.

That's about what it is, she said. *Every year. Don't take it hard.* She looked them over, the sunburnt ones and the hungover ones and the ones newly in love. *Folks come out there with their hands full. Somebody they want. Somebody they can't stand. A blanket. You can't hear it holding all that. It's the same set next year.*

She put the truck in gear. As it rolled by, those standing nearest could read the side rail in daylight for the first time. She had copied it, she once told the nurse, out of her mother's old blue Oxford Blake, which says *bends* where the newer books say *binds*, and she had never seen cause to change it.

> *He who bends to himself a Joy*
> *Doth the winged life destroy;*
> *But he who kisses the Joy as it flies*
> *Lives in Eternity's sunrise.*
>
> *— William Blake, "Eternity"*

• • •

The next year most of the block went out again. Dale left his camera in the tent and rode out with nothing in his hands. A shark of one kind or another showed up around two, as one will. He let somebody else walk over and talk to it. At twenty past six the sun came up on the far side of the playa, and he was on his feet.

There were five of them that year. Bernadette said five was a lot.

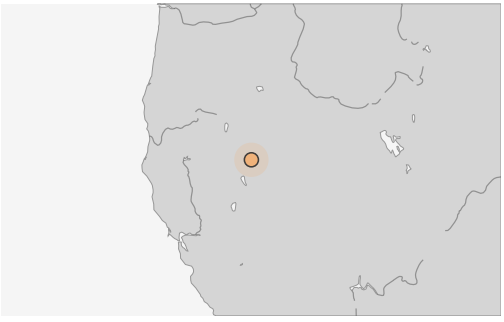
Background

The verses

> *Few are there among men who arrive at the other shore (become Arhats); the other people here run up and down the shore.*
>
> Dhammapada 85, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But those who, when the law has been well preached to them, follow the law, will pass across the dominion of death, however difficult to overcome.*
>
> Dhammapada 86, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the people of one street in Sāvatthī band together, give alms in common, and resolve to spend a whole night listening to the Dhamma. They cannot do it. Some are overcome by desire and go home, some are overcome by anger, and the rest sit nodding in their places and hear nothing. When the monks talk it over the next day, the Buddha says that beings mostly live clinging to existence, and that those who reach the other shore are few. Read the full commentary story.



Black Rock City, Nevada

Black Rock City, 2002

Burning Man has been held since the 1990s on the playa of the Black Rock Desert in Pershing County, Nevada, the bed of the vanished Lake Lahontan. For one week a city is built there and then removed. Nothing is sold in it but ice and coffee, and gifting is one of its stated principles. In 2002 the theme was The Floating World, and 28,979 people came. The Man stood on a forty-foot lighthouse, the curved streets were named for the parts of a ship from Bowsprit back to Abyss, and the radial avenues were numbered as compass bearings from 60 to 300 degrees. The large sound camps were placed at the two ends of the arc, at 60 and 300. On the Friday, the organizers' own account says, a brief blinding dust storm in the late afternoon turned

to showers and ended in a rainbow. The orange perimeter fence, put up to catch windblown trash, marks the limit of the event.

All-night dancing came to the playa with the San Francisco rave crews of the mid-1990s, and the music they brought descends from house, which Black DJs in Chicago built in the early 1980s out of disco, soul and drum machines. A set that ends at sunrise is one of the event's customs. William Blake wrote the four lines called "Eternity" in his notebook in the 1790s. The text here is the one John Sampson printed in the Oxford edition of 1913; the manuscript's first line is now usually read "binds." The block on Mizzen, the flatbed and Bernadette are invented.

After the story about listening to the Dhamma from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 85 and 86). The original. Verse from William Blake's "Eternity" as printed in the Oxford edition of 1913. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

6.11

White City

Making its dust my bed, its loneliest wastes
My dwelling, and its meanest things my mates
— Edwin Arnold, The Light of Asia, Book the Fourth

The way it come down the line, in the willows below the tank at Minot.

I. The Tank

Minot, North Dakota · October 1913

There was a water tank on the Great Northern a little east of the Minot yards, and one moniker had been cut into its timbers every fall for the best part of twenty years, each cut under the last: WHITE CITY, the month and the year, and on the day he left, an arrow pointing south. A man coming in off the threshing with his season's money in his shoe could read on that tank whether White City was still holding down the jungle in the willows. If the newest date had no arrow under it, he walked down to the river before he walked into town.

White City was forty-five that year and had been on the road since he was twenty-five. He shocked and pitched like anybody from July to freeze-up, on the rigs north of town. When the threshing shut down he kept the camp on the Mouse River for two weeks or three, until the river skimmed over. He hustled the wood. He kept forty-odd tin cans scoured with sand and hung bottom side up on the willow stubs so they would not fill with rain and rust: lard pails for cooking, the big square ones for boiling up clothes, tomato cans for coffee. Nobody had asked him to. But men who had come through that camp told it in other camps, as far off as the Wenatchee apples, that it was the cleanest jungle on the Great North-

ern, and that the stiff who kept it would tell you something if you wanted it told, after he had heard you out.

The name was from Chicago. He had been a plasterer's helper on the World's Fair, mixing staff, which is plaster and hemp, and laying it over lath to make the palaces the newspapers called the White City. In September of 1893, with the palaces long built and no work, he went one Monday into the big Art Palace on the lake front, where they were holding a congress of all the religions, because there were seats. A thin young man from Ceylon, dressed in white, read a long paper. He went by a title that somebody on the bench said meant a fellow with no house. White City remembered that. A week later he saw a paper-covered book about that man's teacher on a stall in State Street, and gave a dime for it.

The Fair shut at the end of October, and the banks had been shutting all summer. That winter he slept with other men out of work in the empty palaces. In January he stood in the crowd and watched the Peristyle burn. When the rest of it went, in July, he was shocking wheat in Kansas, and a man read it to him out of a newspaper.

He had the book yet. It was sewn into a square of kitchen oilcloth, and he did not need to open it.

That October the freeze shut the rigs down all in a week. Fifty men came into the willows in one afternoon, off a drag from the west and another down the Soo from Kenmare. They had passed the season on the rigs around Stanley and Berthold and up the Mouse River loop. They had come to see him.

II. The Season

The jungle on the Mouse River · the same afternoon

IN A JUNGLE NOBODY ASKS A MAN HIS NAME OR WHERE HE WAS raised. White City asked each of them one thing, where he had been since July. Then he went on peeling potatoes into the big can and let the man say.

A Dane had pitched bundles for a rig north of Berthold, daylight to dark, at three dollars, and been docked for every hour it rained. He had

slept in the straw stack, because the farmer's wife would not have harvest hands in the barn with the lanterns.

Two of them had been in Minot in August, when the Wobblies got up on boxes at the street corners and the town swore in fifty special police. They had been held in a bullpen outside the jail, and the fire company had turned the hose on them. When the bullpen was full, the rest were put in the stockyard pens beside the Great Northern track. They were offered their dinner if they would break rock for it. One of the two had broken the rock. He said so, and nobody in the willows said anything.

A brakeman out of Williston had wanted a dollar a division or hit the grit. A man with eighty cents had hit it, at twenty miles an hour, and he rolled his sleeve to show them the arm.

A stiff called Ohio Red had gone between the cars at Towner, in the dark, reaching for the ladder. The others on that train had put in a quarter apiece, and a preacher in Towner had read over him for nothing. Nobody knew what name to give the preacher. They gave him the moniker, and it is on a board there.

A boy from Indiana, seventeen, on his first season, had come off a rig near Kenmare with forty-one dollars. Two men with a pistol went through a boxcar full of harvest hands outside Burlington and took all of it, and his shoes, and put the whole car off on the grade. He had walked into Minot with his feet tied up in a grain sack.

A man from the pineries had made the best stake of his life, a hundred and twelve dollars, and had not slept three hours together since, for holding it.

Another had last year's story. Ninety dollars, one night, in a blind pig on Third Street, in a dry state. He had ninety on him again and could feel it wanting to go.

Some of them mended while they talked. A Syrian woman who walked the branch lines with a case of drawers on her back had sold them needles and thread at Stanley.

It took until dark. White City heard every one of them to the end. He asked the Dane how the straw had been to sleep in, and the Dane, surprised, said it was warm, and that you could see the whole sky.

When the mulligan was eaten and each man had washed his can in the river, he spoke. He was not a talker and it did not take long.

III. The King's Boy

By the fire · that night

YOU TALK LIKE MEN THAT HAD A THING TOOK OFF YOU, HE SAID. *A house. A woman, some of you. I talked that way ten years.*

There was a rich man's boy in India one time. A king's boy. He had three houses, one for the heat and one for the cold and one for the rains, and a wife, and a new baby. He walked out on the whole spread one night, on purpose, and went on the bum. He bummed his chuck at back doors with a bowl for the better part of fifty years, and kings came down to the road to ask him how it was done. A man wrote it up. This is the boy talking, the night he goes. He means the ground. The earth.

> *I choose*
> *To tread its paths with patient, stainless feet,*
> *Making its dust my bed, its loneliest wastes*
> *My dwelling, and its meanest things my mates:*
> *Clad in no prouder garb than outcasts wear,*
> *Fed with no meats save what the charitable*
> *Give of their will, sheltered by no more pomp*
> *Than the dim cave lends or the jungle-bush,*
>
> *— The Light of Asia, Book the Fourth*

It goes on. That is the part I mean.

He went out of the dark into the white. That is all I ever got of it, and it was enough to go on. I know something about white. I mixed the White City. It was plaster and hemp on lath, with white lead blown on it out of a hose, and inside every palace was a shed. It burned in two nights. So I don't mean that kind.

The kind I mean, you have had already. You had it on top of a car coming out of Stanley at four in the morning, with frost on the running board and not a dime in your kick, and you felt all right and could not think why. You had it in

that straw. You took it for a mistake. It was the thing itself, and it is what the boy went out for. Next time it comes, don't hunt around for what is wrong. Stay in it. Like it on purpose.

Third Street will have its doors open tomorrow. I am no sky pilot. I only say they have nothing in there as good as what you had on top of that car, and they want the whole stake for it.

You know the law in here. No man calls a can his own except while he is cooking in it. Take that law out of the willows with you. The stake is a can. So is your name, and your sore back, and whatever was done to you in August. Use it, scour it, turn it bottom up for the next man.

And boil up. I don't only mean your shirt.

He was quiet a while, and fed the fire.

You have met one or two that had it steady. They come into a camp and it gets quieter. They are not headed for anyplace better and they are not sore at anyplace behind. A bull can't do much with a man like that. He is as loose in the Minot stockyard as he is on the road. There is a kind of a shine on him, and you know it when you see it.

> *As one who stands on yonder snowy horn*
> *Having nought o'er him but the boundless blue,*
> *So, these sins being slain, the man is come*
> *NIRVANA's verge unto.*
>
> *— The Light of Asia, Book the Eighth*

That last is the boy's word for it, White City said. *I never found an American one.*

Then he got up and banked the fire.

• • •

What came of it is told more than one way. It is agreed that in the morning thirty-some of the fifty walked up to the Minot post office before they went anyplace else, and bought money orders made out to themselves at General Delivery in Minneapolis or Spokane or wherever they meant to winter, paper that a stickup man cannot spend. It is agreed that

the man with the hundred and twelve dollars slept that night from the time he lay down. The one who had lost ninety on Third Street lost it again. He came back down to the willows on the third day and scoured cans, and nobody said anything about that either.

The boy from Indiana went south on the Soo with White City and was seen with him the next fall, pitching bundles north of Berthold, in shoes.

The rest is what men say. They say that for years afterward you would meet a stiff now and then on the Great Northern, or out in the Wenatchee apples, who came into a camp quiet and hustled wood before he sat down, and who asked a man one thing, where he had been since July, and then let him say.

White City left the night the river skimmed over. On the tank the arrow was cut under that year's date, yellow in the gray wood. In the willows the cans hung bottom side up on the stubs, forty-odd of them, scoured and dry, and not one of them anybody's.

Background

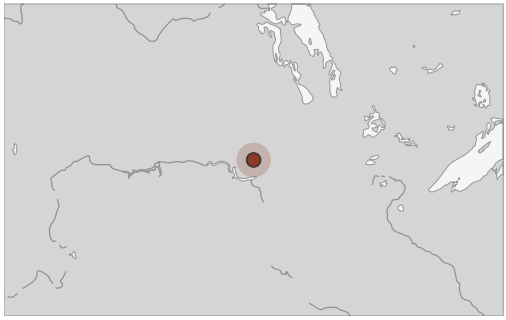
The verses

> *A wise man should leave the dark state (of ordinary life), and follow the bright state (of the Bhikshu). After going from his home to a homeless state, he should in his retirement look for enjoyment where there seemed to be no enjoyment. Leaving all pleasures behind, and calling nothing his own, the wise man should purge himself from all the troubles of the mind.*
>
> Dhammapada 87–88, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Those whose mind is well grounded in the (seven) elements of knowledge, who without clinging to anything, rejoice in freedom from attachment, whose appetites have been conquered, and who are full of light, are free (even) in this world.*
>
> Dhammapada 89, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the slightest in the collection. Fifty monks who have spent the three months of the rains retreat in the kingdom of Kosala come to Jetavana at the end of the season to see the Buddha. He listens to the account of their season, and then gives them three verses on the life they have taken up: out of the dark state into the bright one, from home into homelessness, delight looked for

in the solitude where it is hardest to find, nothing called one's own, the mind cleaned, and freedom here and not later. Many of them reach the first stages of awakening. (The Pāli title says five hundred visiting monks; the story itself says fifty.) Read the full commentary story.



Minot, North Dakota

The harvest stiffs, 1913

Before the combine, the wheat of the northern plains was cut, shocked and threshed by tens of thousands of migrant men who followed the harvest north by freight train from Oklahoma to the Canadian line and were paid off when the freeze stopped the threshing rigs. In the summer of 1915 the paper of the Industrial Workers of the World reported posted harvest wages in North Dakota averaging $2.50 a day, with $3 around Minot, warned that "stickups" were working that district, and told men to send their stakes ahead by postal money order. Between jobs they lived in "jungles," camps near a water tank and a stream. Nels Anderson, who had been a hobo before he was a sociologist, set down the jungle's law in The Hobo (1923): "no one can call a vessel his except at the time he uses it," and cans are to be cleaned, dried and left "turned bottom side up so that they will not fill with rainwater and rust." Jack London's The Road (1907) describes the names cut into railroad water tanks with a date and a direction: "Water-tanks are tramp directories." Minot, founded by the Great Northern in 1886 and reached by the Soo Line in 1893, was a wide-open town in a state that had been dry since statehood. In August 1913 it jailed IWW street speakers and their supporters in a bullpen and then in the Great Northern stockyard, as Prairie Public's account of the Wobblies in Minot tells it. The jungle on the river, White City and the fifty are invented.

The World's Columbian Exposition of 1893 was built largely of staff, plaster and fiber on temporary frames, sprayed white. It closed on October 30 in the middle of a national depression. Chicago's unemployed sheltered in the empty buildings that winter; a fire on January 8, 1894 destroyed the Peristyle, and another in July took most of what was left. During the Fair, the World's Parliament of Religions met

downtown, and on September 18 the young Ceylonese Buddhist Anagarika Dharmapala, dressed in white, read his paper there. *Anagārika* is Pāli for "homeless one," the same word the verse uses. Edwin Arnold's The Light of Asia (1879), a life of the Buddha in English verse, was one of the first books to carry that story to ordinary Western readers. The lines White City says are from Books Four and Eight.

After the story of the fifty visiting monks from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 87–89). The original. Scripture from Edwin Arnold's The Light of Asia (1879). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 7

The Venerable

7.1

Cedar Bark

Why should we mourn, or think our lot is hard?
'Tis not so; all is right!
— William Clayton, "Come, Come, Ye Saints"

As it was told, under the Red Hill in St. George.

I. The Ledge

St. George, Utah · May 1953

Orson Hale had been patriarch of the stake for fourteen years, and before that he had run cattle on the Arizona Strip for fifty, and he still walked like a man who expected to be on a horse by noon. He was eighty-two. He gave blessings three afternoons a week in an adobe house in Dr. Merrill Jarvis's orchard on the Santa Clara bench, under fig trees and pomegranates, with his grandnephew Del at a card table in the corner taking down every word on a portable Royal. His wife had kept the record for him until she died, and Del, home from his mission in Argentina, had taken it over the week of the funeral.

The house had been the doctor's grandmother's. The doctor had come home from the Pacific in 1945 with a Bronze Star and no use for church, and his wife had died the next spring of a cancer he had found too late, and in the summer after that Brother Hale had come out to the orchard without being asked and sat on the porch with him every evening for a month and said almost nothing. In the fall the doctor gave him a key. *The house is better used,* he said. *Come out when you want.* People drove out from town and up from Hurricane and over from Mesquite, young men going on missions and women with sick husbands and boys about to be

married, and sat on the bench under the figs until Del came out and called their names.

Brother Hale's cousin Lyman had expected the calling himself. He had expected it in 1939 and he expected it still. He was seventy-six and had been a bishop once and was not anymore, and over the winter he had begun to say in priesthood meeting and at the post office that Orson was too old, that a man who got his words wrong could not be trusted with the Lord's, that somebody ought to write to Salt Lake. Lately he had been seen in the store on Main Street with Darrell Pace, who had had his own father sent up to the state hospital at Provo in March and taken over the store and the sheep permits both, and who was said to have offered to drive Lyman to Salt Lake himself.

Brother Hale knew all of it. When Del told him, he said, *Lyman has always been a worker,* and went back to his supper.

On the evening of Monday the eighteenth of May he walked out from his house on the north side of town as he did every evening, up the wash under the Red Hill where the white letters of DIXIE stood on the Sugarloaf. The sun was down behind the Pine Valley Mountains and the red rock above him had gone the color of a stove lid. Del was a hundred yards behind with a flashlight, because the family had begun insisting.

Del heard the rock before he saw it. It came off the ledge above the wash, a block of sandstone the size of a washtub, and struck the slope and burst. Most of it went past. One splinter as long as a table knife skipped off a boulder and went through the side of the old man's shoe.

Up on the ledge, against the last light, somebody stood for a moment and then was not there.

Brother Hale sat down on the boulder. When Del got to him he was unlacing the shoe.

Was that Lyman? Del said. *Uncle Orson, was that Lyman up there?*

Help me with this, said Brother Hale. *Then go get your car.*

II. Burow's Solution

The Jarvis orchard · the same evening

THE DOCTOR HAD BEEN EATING SUPPER STANDING AT HIS counter. He put down the plate and turned on every light in the adobe house.

The splinter had gone in at the outside of the left foot below the ankle bone and come out an inch farther along. The shoe had held most of it. The doctor cut the sock off with surgical scissors and cleaned the wound with soap and boiled water and then with Zephiran, and the old man watched him do it as if the foot belonged to somebody else and he had been asked to keep an eye on it.

I can give you something, the doctor said. He had a Syrette of morphine in his bag he had carried since Okinawa and never used on anybody at home.

Keep it for somebody who wants it.

The doctor packed the wound and laid over it a pad of gauze soaked in Burow's solution, which drew the swelling and closed the small vessels, and bound the whole foot in an elastic bandage to the middle of the shin. He had done it a hundred times. A wet pack like that did its work for a few hours, and then it had to come off before it dried and set and began to pull. He told Del so. He told Brother Hale so.

At nine the telephone rang. It was a farmer in Toquerville, twenty-five miles up the highway, whose wife had been in labor since noon and was not getting anywhere.

Go on, Brother Hale said.

I'll be back by midnight, said the doctor. *One o'clock at the latest. Don't anybody touch that bandage. I'll take it off myself.*

He drove out with his bag on the seat beside him, past the white temple standing up in the dark, and out through Washington and up the highway toward Leeds.

III. Toquerville

Before dawn · Tuesday, May 19

THE BABY WAS TURNED THE WRONG WAY. THE DOCTOR WORKED until two, and then until three, with the farmer's mother at the foot of the bed, and at a quarter to five he delivered a boy, blue and furious and alive. He went out to the pump in the yard to wash.

The sky over the Hurricane Cliffs was beginning to go gray. He had his sleeves rolled up and his hands under the water when the whole valley went white.

It was not lightning. It had no direction. Every fence post, every leaf on the cottonwoods along the ditch, every pebble in the yard stood up sharp and shadowless for a long second, and then the light went pink and drained away to the west behind the Pine Valley Mountains, and it was dark again, and a rooster that had been asleep began to crow. The farmer came out on the porch in his stocking feet and stood beside him.

That's another one, he said. *That's the ninth this spring. You can set your clock by them.*

The doctor looked at his watch. It was five minutes after five. The bandage had been on the old man's foot for eight hours.

Then the farmer's mother called him from the door, and he went in, because the young woman had begun to bleed. He was with her until the bleeding stopped and for an hour after, until he was sure, and the sun was well up when he got back into the car. The mother lived. He drove south with the sun on his left hand. Past Leeds, past Harrisburg, past the black lava above Washington, he did the arithmetic again and again, the way he had once counted hours on a hospital ship: how long a wet pack took to dry in a closed room in May, how tight the elastic would draw as the foot swelled under it, what an old man's skin did when it was pinched for half a night. He told himself Del would have had the sense to loosen it. He remembered telling Del not to touch it.

At the east edge of St. George a station wagon was parked across half the highway and two young men in coveralls were stopping cars. One of them walked around the doctor's Chevrolet holding a meter on a cord

close to the tires and the fenders, and the meter clicked and then chattered, and the young man straightened up and looked at the sky, which was clear and pale and empty, as if he could see something in it.

Your car needs to be washed, sir, he said. *There's a station in town that's doing it. Then you'll want to go inside somewhere.*

I'm a doctor. I have a patient on the Santa Clara road.

Yes, sir. Everybody's supposed to go inside. It's only for a little while. There's no danger.

The radio in the service station said the same thing. A boy with a hose washed the Chevrolet down to the hubcaps while the doctor stood under the overhang with the station owner, and the water ran off the car and down the gutter of Main Street in the sun. Then a highway patrolman whose four children the doctor had delivered came and stood by him and said, *Doc, I'm sorry, they want everybody in,* and took him by the elbow across to the café, where twelve people sat at the counter with the blinds drawn, and a waitress poured coffee, and nobody said very much. Children's faces went by the window now and then on their way somewhere, running. Somebody said the schools had let recess out at the regular time.

He sat there until noon. He thought about the foot. He found that he could not think about anything else, about the meter or the empty sky or the children, about what *no danger* meant in the mouth of a young man who had been told to say it. He could think about the foot because he had tied the bandage himself.

IV. Cedar Bark

The orchard · Tuesday afternoon

BROTHER HALE WAS SITTING ON THE PORCH OF THE ADOBE house in a kitchen chair with his left foot bare on a cushion, in the shade of the big fig. Del was at the card table inside the open door, typing. The bandage lay rolled on the porch boards beside the chair, dry and stiff as a stick.

The doctor knelt on the boards and took the foot in his hands.

Where the splinter had gone in and come out there were two thin lines, pale and closed, like the marks a hatband leaves. There was no swelling. The skin moved over the ankle bone the way it should. On the porch rail lay what had come off the wound in the night, a dark curled strip the length of his finger, and it looked like nothing so much as the bark that peels off a cedar fence post in long shreds when the post is old and the bark has finished with it.

What time did you take it off?

Del came to the door. *Midnight. He woke me up. He said, Brother Jarvis would have had that off by now. He said, Brother Jarvis is sitting up somewhere worrying about it, so take it off. I said you told us not to. He said, You take it off.* Del looked at his shoes. *So I did. And that was already on it.* He nodded at the rail. *It came away this morning when he put his foot down. All in one piece.*

The doctor stayed on his knees. He held the foot a while longer, because he did not trust himself yet to let go of it.

Did you have pain in the night? he said. *Tell me the truth.*

Brother Hale looked at him with great kindness, the way he had looked at him across this porch in the summer of 1946.

Merrill, he said, *I haven't had any pain since the winter of ninety-seven.*

The doctor waited.

I was twenty-six. I was out past Mount Trumbull with two hundred head and the snow came, and I lay under a cedar three nights with my horse, and I thought that was the end of the road. I thought about everything I had. I thought about everybody that had ever done anything to me. Then I didn't. He moved his bare toes on the cushion. *That was the end of the road, as it turned out. I just didn't die on it. Everything since then has been the trip home.*

And Lyman?

Lyman is worried about who will do this when I'm gone. Somebody ought to be. He smiled. *You know the verse. You sang it in Primary. Your mother used to sing it in that kitchen.*

He did not sing it. He said it, the fourth verse, in his ordinary voice, the voice he used for blessings, while Del's hands rested on the keys of the Royal and did not type.

And should we die before our journeys thro',
Happy day! all is well!
We then are free from toil and sorrow, too;
With the just we shall dwell.

— William Clayton, "Come, Come, Ye Saints" (1846), verse 4

The doctor sat back on his heels on the porch boards. Out past the orchard the highway ran east toward Washington, and the fields lay green under the same clear sky as any day in May, with nothing in it to see, and down on Main Street the boy with the hose would still be washing cars. Nobody on that porch could do one thing about any of it. He had known that since five minutes after five.

He had been sitting up all night, in Toquerville and in the café, with a bandage, because a bandage was a thing he could take off.

Your hands are shaking, said Brother Hale.

I've been up since yesterday.

Then sit, the old man said. *Del, get Brother Jarvis a chair.*

Del brought the other kitchen chair out and set it beside his uncle's in the shade of the fig. The doctor sat. After a while he leaned down, untied his own shoes and took them off, and set his feet on the cool boards. Inside, Del typed what had been said, all of it, because he typed everything. The strip of bark lay on the rail until the wind took it.

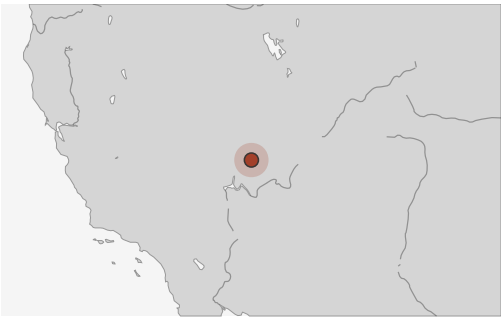
Background

The verse

> *There is no suffering for him who has finished his journey, and abandoned grief, who has freed himself on all sides, and thrown off all fetters.*
>
> Dhammapada 90, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha's jealous cousin Devadatta, with the backing of Prince Ajātasattu, rolls a rock down from Vulture's Peak; a splinter wounds the Buddha's foot. He is carried to the mango grove of the physician Jīvaka, who dresses the wound with an astringent and binds it, then goes into the city to a patient, meaning to come back and take the bandage off. He returns too late; the city gate has

shut, and he spends the night afraid that the bandage, left on, is causing the Buddha great pain. Knowing his thought, the Buddha has Ānanda remove it, and the wound vanishes like bark peeling from a tree. At dawn Jīvaka asks whether he suffered, and the Buddha answers that for one who has finished the journey all suffering is gone, as it was from the night of his awakening. Read the full commentary story.



St. George, Utah

St. George, Utah, *1953*

In the spring of 1953 the Atomic Energy Commission set off eleven atmospheric tests at the Nevada Test Site in the series called Upshot-Knothole. The ninth, Harry, a 32-kiloton device on a tower, was fired before dawn on May 19, and the wind carried its fallout northeast over St. George, a town of about forty-five hundred in the cotton-and-fruit country Latter-day Saint settlers called Dixie since the cotton mission of 1861. An AEC monitor in town saw his instrument go off its scale around nine in the morning. Residents were asked by radio to stay indoors for a time and were told there was no danger; cars coming from the St. George area were checked with counters and washed at St. George, Cedar City, Mesquite and other points. Children at some schools were outside at recess while the fallout settled. The shot was later called "Dirty Harry." Earlier that spring thousands of sheep driven from Nevada winter range to lambing grounds near Cedar City sickened and died, and their owners' lawsuits against the government failed.

Rates of leukemia and other cancers among the downwinders of southern Utah, Nevada and Arizona became a long public fight. In 1990 Congress passed the Radiation Exposure Compensation Act, which offered payments to people with certain illnesses and apologized on behalf of the nation. The patriarch in this story holds a real office: in each stake of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints a patriarch lays his hands on members' heads and gives each one a blessing, usually once in a lifetime, which is written down as he speaks and kept. The verse he says is the fourth of William Clayton's "All Is Well," written on the trail across Iowa in April 1846 and sung ever after as "Come, Come, Ye Saints."

After the story of Jīvaka's question from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 90). The original. Hymn text from *Latter-Day Saints Congregational Hymns* (1919), no. 67. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7.2

Castle Rock

Dweller and dwelling are rivals in impermanence, both are fleeting as the dewdrop that hangs on the petals of the morning-glory.
— Kamo no Chōmei, Hōjōki

Nyoze gamon, in Block 54.

I. The Laundry Room

Tule Lake Segregation Center, Newell, California · January 1946

THE WAR HAD BEEN OVER FOR FIVE MONTHS, AND THE CAMP was emptying the way a lake goes down in a dry year, from the edges in. Whole blocks stood shut. The stoves were cold in barracks where families had lived for three years, and the wind came down off the Oregon line and blew the tarpaper loose and nobody nailed it back. The ones still inside the wire were the ones the government had not decided about yet: men who had answered no on the questionnaire, families who had come from other camps to stay together, young people who had signed away their citizenship in the winter of 1944 and 1945 and now wanted it back and had a lawyer from San Francisco trying to get it for them. Hearings were held. Lists were posted. Some names went on a list for a ship to Japan, and some went on a list for the Justice Department camp at Crystal City, Texas, and some were let go.

Hirasaka-sensei's name came through on the twenty-eighth of January. He had been the priest of the Buddhist church in Florin, in the strawberry country south of Sacramento, for nineteen years before the war, and of the Buddhist church in Block 4 at Tule Lake for three and a half. He was sixty-one. He had a soft voice and very little hair and a black robe that his wife had turned twice, and he said the Nembutsu so quietly that

people sitting in the back of the mess hall on Sundays could only tell he was saying it by watching his mouth.

That evening after service he stood up at the front, where the altar was a packing crate draped in purple cloth with the scroll hung above it, and said that he had been released, that he was going home to Florin to open the temple again, and that anyone else whose papers had come through might go with him. The train would be on the eleventh of February. He sat down. That was the announcement.

Eleven people had their papers. All the next week they got ready. They built crates out of scrap lumber from the empty blocks and stenciled their names on the sides with shoe blacking. They took down the curtains they had sewn from mattress ticking and folded them into the crates. The Yamane brothers sold their radio. Mrs. Okada gave away her potted geraniums one by one to the women who were staying, with instructions.

Goro Tanikawa's papers had come through with the rest. He was forty-one, born in Florin, sent to Hiroshima at six to be raised by his grandparents and sent back at sixteen with no English, so that he spoke a careful Japanese the young people laughed at and a careful English the old people could not follow. He had worked the coal crew all three years at Tule Lake, shoveling coal off the cars at the siding and carrying it block to block in winter, and he wore the same navy pea coat from the clothing allowance that he had been issued in 1943, patched at both elbows with feed sacking, and slept in it in the cold months. He ate whatever the mess hall gave him and did not go back for more. When the other men on the crew sat down in the lee of the coal pile to smoke, he went on shoveling, and when anybody asked him why, he said the coal did not know it was break time.

He did not build a crate. On the Saturday before the train, while the others were nailing lids down, he was in the laundry barrack of Block 54 with his sleeves pushed up, washing his two shirts and his other pair of trousers in the concrete tub, and his socks, and the pea coat, which took the whole afternoon and an inch of the soap.

Look at him, said Shig Yamane, at the window. *He's not going anywhere.*

It was not an unkind thing to say. Everybody knew the Tanikawas. Goro's mother was in Block 54, and his three sisters and their husbands, and nine nieces and nephews, and his father's cousin's family from Elk Grove, and two old aunts who had come from Rohwer in Arkansas so as to be with the rest. They filled four barracks. One of his sisters' husbands had renounced in 1945 and was on the list for Crystal City, and the sister was going with him, and the children. The mother was sixty-nine and had a cough that did not go away.

He'll walk us to the gate, Shig said. *That's as far as he'll get.*

He'll get as far as Castle Rock, said his brother. *Then he'll remember something.*

II. The Gate

February 11, 1946

THE TRUCKS CAME FOR THE CRATES AT SEVEN AND FOR THE people at nine. It was very cold and very clear. Out past the fences the old lake bed lay flat and white with frost to the bluff of Castle Rock, which stood up from the plain like the prow of a ship, and on top of it, small and black, the cross the first people in the camp had carried up in 1942, before Tule Lake was made the place for the disloyal.

Goro walked out with the others. He carried a cloth bundle about the size of a bed pillow, which was everything he had, and his mother walked beside him as far as the administration building and then stopped, and he bowed to her, and she went back.

At the gate the soldier checked their names against a sheet on a clipboard. Hirasaka-sensei waited until all the names had been checked. Then he turned around to Goro.

There will be funerals, he said. *There are old people here who will not see the end of this. Somebody has to say the sutra for them, and they would rather it were somebody who knew them. On the fifteenth it is Nehan-e. Somebody has to put out the flowers. When the Crystal City list goes, somebody has to be at the train.* He looked past Goro at the long rows of tarpaper going back to-

ward Block 54. *Most of the people who are left in there are yours. Go back and stay with them until it closes.*

Goro bowed and went back through the gate with his bundle. He did not say anything. He did not look back at the trucks, and the soldier wrote something on the clipboard.

In the truck Shig Yamane leaned over to his brother.

What did I tell you.

Hirasaka-sensei heard him. He did not say anything until the truck had turned onto the highway toward the train and the camp had gone down behind the frost into a long gray line. Then he said, not loudly, *Shig-kun, what is in his bundle?*

Shig did not know.

Two shirts, two pairs of trousers, the socks, a razor, the sutra book I gave him when he was nine, and that coat. He washed them because he was ready to go. He went back because I asked him to. The old man took his gloves off and folded them. *If I had asked you, you would have gone back. You would have gone back angry. He went back the way he would have come.*

Nobody in the truck said anything for a while.

When he was nine years old, the sensei said, *before I ever came to this country, he was in the Sunday school at my father's temple in Hiroshima, and I asked the children what they wanted to be. The others said a doctor, a farmer, a baseball player. Goro said he wanted to be the moon. I asked him why. He said, Because the moon goes into everybody's house and nobody owns it.* He smiled. *I thought that was a strange thing for a child to say. I have been watching him go in and out of his family's rooms for three years now, and he goes in like the moon going into a bucket of water. It is in there. It is not wet.*

III. Swans

The Southern Pacific, north along the lake · the same day

NORTH OF THE CAMP THE RAILROAD RAN UP THE EAST SIDE OF the old lake bed toward Klamath Falls, and off to the west, a mile or two across the fields, lay the open water that was left of Tule Lake, where the refuge was. It had a skin of ice at the margins and open blue in the

MIDDLE. THE SWANS WERE STILL ON IT. THERE WERE HUNDREDS of them, white on the blue, so many that from the train they looked like a long drift of snow that had not yet melted. Every winter of the camp they had come down in the fall, and every spring the people had stood at the north fence to watch them go.

As the train came even with them the swans began to lift. They did not all go at once. A few at a time they ran along the water on their black feet, beating, and pulled up into the air with their necks out straight, and turned north, calling to each other in a high soft voice like people far off talking, and the others followed. They did not circle over the lake. They did not look back at the water. They had eaten there all winter, and slept there, and it had held them up, and they went.

The Yamane brothers had their faces at the window. Mrs. Okada held her last geranium on her lap.

Hirasaka-sensei watched the swans with the others until they were gone. Then he took out of his coat pocket a thin paperbound book, the one he carried everywhere, the account of a ten-foot-square hut that a court poet had built for himself on a hillside outside Kyoto more than seven hundred years before, after the fires and the famine and the earthquake had taught him what a house was. Most of the older people in the car had learned the first lines of it in school, in Japan or in the Japanese school at Florin on Saturdays. The sensei did not read the first lines. He turned to the end and read the place where the old poet, very content in his hut at last, catches himself being content.

> *What the Buddha has taught to men is this—Thou shalt not cleave to any of the things of this world. So 'tis a sin even to grow fond of this straw-thatched cabin, and to find happiness in this life of peace is a hindrance to salvation.*
>
> *— Kamo no Chōmei, Hōjōki XVII, tr. Minakata Kumagusu and F. Victor Dickins (1905)*

He built that hut so he could take it apart, the sensei said. *Two carts would carry it. He did not fasten it to the ground.* He put the book away. *He still had to tell himself not to love it.*

Shig Yamane looked out the window a long time. There was nothing on the lake by then but the ice at the edges and the blue water and a few feathers going round in the current.

IV. Not Fastened

Tule Lake · March 1946

Goro said the sutra at four funerals in February and March. One of them was his father's cousin from Elk Grove. He put out the flowers for Nehan-e on the fifteenth, paper chrysanthemums the women folded from old mess-hall menus because there was nothing growing yet, and he swept the Block 4 church every morning after the coal was in, even after there was no one left to come to it but his mother and the two aunts from Rohwer.

On the nineteenth of March the last renunciants went to the train for Crystal City, four hundred of them and their families, and his sister and her husband and their children with them. He carried his sister's crate. He stood at the siding until the train had gone south out of sight, as the sensei had asked, and then he walked back.

The camp closed the next day. He left with his mother and the aunts on the last trucks. He had his bundle, and the coat, which he had washed again.

The next year the government began giving the barracks away. Veterans who had drawn homesteads in the old lake bed, in a lottery held at the armory in Klamath Falls the week before Christmas, came with flatbed trucks and jacks and took them in halves and thirds, a barrack to a family, and set them down out on the bare reclaimed ground among the potato fields to live in while they built houses. For a year and more the road out of Newell was full of them, long tarpaper buildings riding north and west on trucks, windows rattling, the numbers still painted on their ends.

The Block 4 church went to a man from Merrill who had been in the Navy. He told people afterward that it had come apart easier than any building he had ever seen, as if it had never been nailed down, and that when he got it set on blocks on his place and went in to sweep it out, there was nothing to sweep. The floor was clean to the boards. Somebody had left a broom standing in the corner, and on the wall above where the altar had been, a pale square where a scroll had hung, and he never could get the paint to cover it.

Background

The verse

> *They depart with their thoughts well-collected, they are not happy in their abode;*
> *like swans who have left their lake, they leave their house and home.*
>
> Dhammapada 91, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha announces at Rājagaha that he will set out on a journey in two weeks. While the other monks fire their bowls and dye their robes, Mahā Kassapa, the elder most given to austerities, washes his robes, and the others say he will never leave a city so full of his relatives and supporters; he will go no farther than a nearby cave. On the road the Buddha does send him back, because someone must stay for the city's festivals and misfortunes, and most of the city are Kassapa's people. Kassapa turns back without a word. When the monks say they were right, the Buddha tells them he went back out of obedience, not attachment: he goes among households like the moon, and long ago he had wished for exactly that. He is like a royal swan that leaves a lake and does not look back. Read the full commentary story.

Tule Lake, California

Tule Lake, 1946

Tule Lake, on the old lake bed just south of the Oregon line, opened in May 1942 as one of the ten camps where the government held Japanese Americans removed from the West Coast. In July 1943 it became the segregation center for people judged disloyal, many for their answers to the loyalty questionnaire, along with family members who chose to come with them; it got a double fence, twenty-eight guard towers and a stockade. After a 1944 law made it possible to renounce citizenship in wartime, and the government announced that the camps would close, thousands at Tule Lake renounced, many of them under pressure from inside and outside the fence. In November 1945 the San Francisco lawyer Wayne Collins won a court order that stopped mass deportations two days before a ship was to sail, and hearings followed. On March 19, 1946, the last 406 renunciants and 43 family members went by train to the Justice Department camp at Crystal City, Texas, and the next day Tule Lake, the last of the camps, closed. Its barracks were given away and sold to the homesteaders, many of them veterans chosen by lottery, who settled the reclaimed lake bed. It is now part of Tule Lake National Monument. Collins's lawsuits took until 1968 to restore citizenship to nearly five thousand people.

What was left of the lake became the Tule Lake National Wildlife Refuge in 1928; tundra swans are common there in winter and pass through in early spring and late fall. The book the priest reads is the *Hōjōki*, finished in 1212 by Kamo no Chōmei, a poet who had lived through the fire, whirlwind, famine and earthquake that struck Kyoto in the 1170s and 1180s and retired to a hut ten feet square that he could take apart and carry away in two carts. The English here is the 1905 translation by Minakata Kumagusu and F. Victor Dickins. Shin Buddhist temples keep Nehan-e, the memorial of the Buddha's passing, on February 15.

After the story of the Elder Mahā Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 91). The original. Text from Kamo no Chōmei's *Hōjōki*, translated by Minakata Kumagusu and F. Victor Dickins, *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society* (1905). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7·3

Sukhari

See the birds of the sky, that they don't sow, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns.
— Matthew 6:26

The way I heard it, under the Fremont Bridge.

I. The Heat

Northwest Industrial, Portland, Oregon · June 2021

The village had twenty-two houses, if you called them houses, and everybody did, because that was one of the rules. They were sleeping pods eight feet by ten, framed in two-by-fours and sheathed in plywood by a church youth group from Beaverton and a crew of union carpenters over two Saturdays, each with a door that locked and a window of corrugated plastic and a number painted over the door. They stood in two rows on a gravel lot between a cement terminal and the on-ramp to the Fremont Bridge, and the bridge went over them so high that on clear days its long arch was most of the sky to the east. There was a shipping container fitted out as a kitchen and another for showers, four blue toilets, a chain-link fence, a gate with a sign-in book on a clipboard, and a whiteboard by the gate with the rules written on it in marker. The rules were made at the meeting on Tuesday nights and voted on by everybody who lived there. That summer there were nineteen.

Rose Jim had been chair for two years. She was sixty-eight, a Yakama woman from White Swan who had come down the river at nineteen and spent most of the next forty years on the docks at Terminal 6, lashing and unlashing containers as a casual, never quite getting the hours to be registered. When the big carriers pulled out of Terminal 6 in 2015 and 2016

there was not much left to lash, and the rent on her apartment in St. Johns went up twice in one year after that. She went home to the reservation every August for huckleberries and came back. People asked her why she came back, and she said the village needed a chair. They had elected her because she said the least at meetings, and what she said, people did.

On Saturday the twenty-sixth of June it was a hundred and eight degrees in Portland, the hottest it had ever been. On Sunday it was a hundred and twelve. On Monday it was a hundred and sixteen, and the wires over the MAX tracks sagged in the heat and the trains stopped running. The pods were plywood boxes in the full sun. By ten in the morning you could not put your hand flat on a door.

Rose moved everybody out of the houses and under the on-ramp, where there was shade and a little air coming off the river, and they lay on wet sheets on the concrete with their dogs. Duane, who was seventy-four and had a bad heart, went grey around the mouth on Sunday afternoon, and with the trains stopped they could not get him to the cooling center at the Convention Center until a church van came. On Monday a woman from the county drove by with a pickup full of water and said they were lucky, and Rose asked her lucky how, and the woman said, you have shade.

The one who got them through it was Pavlo, from number fourteen.

He had been in the village since March. He was fifty-eight, a Ukrainian from a village outside Ternopil, a big quiet man with a grey beard cut close and forearms burned on the inside in a ladder of small white scars, the marks bakers get from oven racks. He had come over in 2000 behind his sister, who had married a Pentecostal from Vancouver, and for nineteen years he had worked nights in the bread room of a Slavic bakery in Gresham, and in the first spring of the sickness the bakery had closed and did not open again. Everyone in the village called him Paul. He let them.

All three days of the heat he walked to the gas station on Nicolai Street and back, a mile each way, pulling a cooler on wheels, and filled it with bags of ice, and came back with his shirt black with sweat and the cooler sloshing, and went along the people lying under the ramp and put

ice in towels and the towels on their necks. He did not talk while he did it. Rose watched him go out and come back, out and come back, nine or ten times on the Monday, the hottest day there had ever been, and his lips were moving the whole time, and once, when he went by close enough, she heard that it was not English and that it was the same few words over and over.

Seventy-two people died in the county that weekend, most of them alone in apartments with a fan running. Nobody in the village died.

II. Two Streets

Northwest Twenty-third and Twenty-first Avenues · July

In July the heat broke and the village went back to its routines, and so did Pavlo, and his routines were these.

At six in the morning he signed out at the gate and walked up through the industrial streets, past the scrap yards and the bus barn, and under the freeway, and into Northwest, where the old Victorian houses had been turned into shops and the shops sold soap for eleven dollars a bar. On Twenty-third Avenue there was a bakery with a back door on the alley, and at a quarter to seven every morning a young woman with flour in her eyebrows opened it and put yesterday's bread into a bin for the food bank pickup. The first time Pavlo knocked she had looked at him the way people looked at him now, and then she had looked at his forearms, and asked him where he'd worked.

After that she let him take what he wanted from the bin before the van came. She offered him croissants, and the morning buns with orange peel in them, and the scones, which were the first things people threw out. He thanked her and took two loaves of plain bread. Country bread, rye, a baguette gone hard as a broom handle. No butter in it, nothing sweet. *Just bread, please.* She stopped offering the pastry after a week.

Then he walked back down to the village, a mile and a half, and ate his breakfast with everybody else, the oatmeal Shane made in the kitchen container in a stockpot, with brown sugar if there was any, and washed his bowl. Then he walked back up again, to Twenty-first, where an old

Italian kept a bakery in a storefront and threw out more bread than anybody in Portland, and took two more loaves there, and came home.

Shane, who ran the kitchen and had been a line cook at a hotel downtown until the sickness closed it, said once at the sink: *Two trips? For bread? I could get you a whole case of bread from the food bank. Sandwich bread. Sliced.*

Pavlo said thank you. He did not want sandwich bread.

In the afternoon, when the sun came over the roof of the cement terminal and lay full on the lot, he took the loaves and his knife, a long serrated bread knife with a handle worn pale where his thumb went, the one thing he had brought from Gresham, and he sliced them thin on a cutting board, every slice the same. He laid the slices out on two oven racks he had found behind a restaurant, and set the racks on the flat roof of the shower container, where the steel got hot enough by three o'clock to make a dog yelp. By evening the bread was dry all the way through, light, pale gold, and hard enough to ring when you dropped a piece on the roof. His grandmother had made them like this in the oven after the bread, from the ends of the loaves, for the road and for the hungry months. Sukhari. You could carry them for a month. You could keep them for a year.

He put them in a white plastic bucket that had held frosting, with a lid that snapped down, and carried the bucket into number fourteen, and on the last Thursday of July he went in after it and shut the door, and nobody saw him for five days.

III. Number Fourteen

The village · August

IT WAS KRYSTAL WHO NOTICED FIRST, BECAUSE SHE LIVED IN thirteen and she noticed everything that happened in fourteen. She was the village secretary, thirty-one, from Klamath Falls, and she kept the minutes on a laptop with a cracked screen, and she was frightened of rats beyond what anyone thought was reasonable until she told them why,

WHICH SHE DID ONCE, AT A MEETING, AND AFTER THAT nobody said anything about it again.

He hasn't come out, she said to Shane. *Since Thursday. I hear him. I hear him moving around and I hear him talking. Real quiet. All night.*

Talking to who?

I don't know. It's not English.

It was in the rules that you took your turn on security, four hours on the gate with the clipboard and the radio, and Pavlo had not missed a turn. He had traded all his turns that week ahead of time, to Duane and to a boy named Marcus, and paid them in cigarettes he didn't smoke. That was allowed. But when Shane went and looked at the gate book he saw that Pavlo had signed in on Thursday afternoon and had not signed out, not for the morning bread, not for anything, and he hadn't been to the kitchen for breakfast or for dinner, and nobody had seen him at the showers.

The heat had frightened all of them. They knocked.

He opened the door. He was sitting on his cot, in a clean T-shirt, with a cord of knotted black wool wound around one hand, a hundred knots on it, and in the corner on the floor was the white frosting bucket with its lid off, and next to it a gallon jug of water, half gone. There was nothing else in the house that had not been there before: a blanket, a duffel, a small picture of a saint propped on the windowsill, a hook with his good shirt on it. It smelled like bread.

I'm all right, he said. *Thank you. I am praying.*

He said it the way somebody else might have said I'm reading or I'm watching the game. Then he waited, politely, to see whether they wanted anything else, and when they didn't, he shut the door.

It was all over the village by dinner. Paul had a bucket of food in his house. Paul had a whole bakery in there. Paul was sitting in the dark eating bread out of a bucket and talking to himself. A man who had come in June said Paul was holding, that you didn't sit in a box for five days for no reason, and Shane told him to shut up, but the thing had been said and it went around anyway.

And what was underneath it, which nobody said out loud, was something else. Every one of them stood in lines. The line at the church on Burnside for sack lunches, the line at the county for the paperwork, the line at the clinic, the line for the shower, the line for the phone charger, the line for everything. You stood in the line every day and you said please and thank you to people younger than your kids, and that was what it cost. And here was Paul, who had figured out how to stand in line twice and then not stand in it at all for a week. Who did he think he was.

Krystal said it at the kitchen door, with her arms crossed. *There's a rule. There's supposed to be a rule. You don't keep food in your house. Everybody knows that. That's how you get them.*

But there was not a rule. Shane went and read the whiteboard at the gate to make sure. There were nineteen rules, and they said no weapons, no hard drugs, no violence, no fires, no guests after ten, take your turn on security, take your turn on the toilets, clean up after your dog, and eleven more, and none of them said anything about bread.

So they took it to Rose.

IV. The Rule

Tuesday night · August 10

Rose did not answer them. She finished the cigarette she was smoking, which was one of four she allowed herself a day, and put it out carefully in a coffee can, and walked down the row to number fourteen and knocked.

He let her in. She sat on the only chair, which was a bucket, a different bucket, upside down, and he sat on the cot.

People are worried about you.

I'm sorry. I am fine.

What are you doing in here?

He thought about it for a while. He did not seem to be thinking of what to tell her. He seemed to be thinking of how to say it in English.

Nineteen years I work in the bread room, he said. *At night. Eleven to seven. Mixing, shaping, the ovens. Nobody talks. And all night I say the prayer, the one*

my grandmother taught me. Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me. All night. With the hands I shape the bread and inside I say the prayer, and it goes by itself, like the mixer. Like breathing. Nineteen years.

He turned the wool cord in his fingers.

Then the bakery closes. Then I am here. And every day I walk to the doors, and I knock, and I ask, and the girl is kind, and the old man is kind, and I say thank you, thank you, and the prayer goes. It stops. I come back and I have to start again from the beginning, like a child. So I think, my grandmother made sukhari for the road. I walk two streets one day, and I make sukhari, and then I stay. And it comes back. Since Thursday it is like in the bread room. It goes by itself.

What do you eat?

Two pieces in the morning. Two at night. Water.

Rose looked into the bucket. It was a little less than half full of pale dry slices of bread, all the same thickness, and nothing else. No peanut butter. No cans. Not a cracker. Bread that had been in a bin for the food bank van, cut thin and dried in the sun on the roof of a shower.

She nodded and got up off the bucket and went out.

• • •

The meeting was in the space between the kitchen container and the on-ramp, on folding chairs, with the traffic going over the bridge above them so that you had to wait sometimes for a truck to pass before you could be heard. Seventeen people came, which was a lot. Krystal had the laptop on her knees. Pavlo came too, because Rose asked him to, and sat at the end of a row with his hands in his lap.

Krystal read the complaint. Shane said what he had seen. The man who had come in June started to say what he thought and Rose looked at him and he stopped. Then Rose took her phone out of her shirt pocket and held it out at arm's length, the way she held everything she read now.

I went to Chemawa, she said. Some of them knew what that was and some didn't. *Four years. They read the Bible at us three times a day. I kept two or three things out of it, the way you keep a couple of good things out of a bad house. This is one. This is the oldest rule about food there is.*

She had found it on her phone in the free Bible, which had different words from the one at Chemawa.

> *Moses said to them, "Let no one leave of it until the morning." Notwithstanding they didn't listen to Moses, but some of them left of it until the morning, so it bred worms and became foul; and Moses was angry with them.*
>
> *— Exodus 16:19–20*

That was bread from heaven, Rose said, *and it still drew worms. Ours draws rats. So here's twenty. Nobody keeps food in their house overnight. Not bread, not chips, not candy. You get a shelf in the kitchen with your name on it, and it goes there, and nobody touches anybody's shelf. That's the motion.*

It passed fifteen to two. Krystal typed it and then got up and wrote it on the whiteboard at the gate in green marker, in her neat round hand. *20. No food in houses overnight. Kitchen shelf w/ your name.*

When she came back, Shane said what everybody was waiting for somebody to say.

So what about Paul?

Rose put her phone in her lap.

What about him? He didn't break a rule. There wasn't one till tonight. And you all go look in that bucket before you say another word about it. It's bread out of a bin that was going to the food bank, that the food bank would have thrown out on Friday. He dried it on the shower roof. He eats four pieces a day with water. He took his security turns, he paid for the trades, and he got every one of you through the heat with ice on your neck.

She looked at the man who had come in June.

Some people get through a day by holding on to everything they can get. He gets through it holding on to about as little as a person can. That's not the same thing. I don't know what it is, but it isn't that.

She picked up the phone again, and scrolled, and found the other one she had kept out of Chemawa, and read it in the new words, slowly, holding the phone out in front of her as a truck went over and shook the bridge and the sound came down around them.

> *See the birds of the sky, that they don't sow, neither do they reap, nor gather into barns. Your heavenly Father feeds them. Aren't you of much more value than they?*
>
> *— Matthew 6:26*

Nobody said anything. Then Krystal typed something, and Shane got up to start the dishes, and the meeting was over.

Pavlo went back to number fourteen and came out with the white bucket, and carried it across the gravel to the kitchen container. Shane gave him a strip of blue painter's tape and a marker, and Pavlo printed his name on the tape in careful capitals, PAUL, and put it on the lid, and set the bucket on the bottom shelf. Every morning after that, and every evening, he came to the kitchen and took two pieces out of it and put the lid back on.

Krystal watched him do it, the first few mornings, from the door of the container. Then she stopped watching. In the third week of August she came to the meeting with a motion of her own, to set aside a shelf for day-old bread from the bakeries on Twenty-third and Twenty-first, for anybody, if somebody would walk up and get it. Pavlo said he would. Shane said he would go too.

V. The Chimney

Chapman Elementary School · September

Every September since her first one in the village, Rose had walked up through Northwest in the evenings to the school on Twenty-sixth Avenue to watch the swifts go down the chimney.

The school was old red brick, and on the side of it stood a big square brick chimney that had not carried smoke in years. For as long as anyone could remember, the Vaux's swifts had come to it in the fall on their way south, thousands of them, and spent the night inside it clinging to the bricks, and the whole city came to watch. Before the sickness, the bird people from Audubon had made it an event, every night in September, with volunteers and parking and two or three thousand people spread out

on the grass slope above the playing field with blankets and pizza and children sliding down the hill on flattened cardboard boxes. In 2020 the bird people had called it off, to keep the crowds down. In 2021 they called it off again.

People came anyway, a few dozen a night, and sat far apart on the slope with masks around their chins, and nobody stopped them. A volunteer with a clicker counter stood at the bottom of the hill counting the birds, because somebody had to.

On a Saturday in the middle of the month Rose asked Pavlo if he wanted to come. Shane came too, and Krystal, who had never been, and Marcus, who brought a skateboard and did not ride it.

They sat on the slope with the sun going down behind the hills. At first there was nothing, and then there were a few, very high, small and dark and fast as thrown things, flickering, with wings that seemed to beat out of time with each other. Then more came in from the north, and from over the river, in loose bunches, and then there were hundreds, and then the sky over the school was full of them, two or three thousand birds, each the size of a man's thumb, turning together in a great slow wheel above the chimney. Their calls came down thin and high, like a lot of small doors creaking.

They don't land, Rose said. *Did you know that? They can't perch. They don't sit in trees. All day they're up there catching bugs. They eat flying and they drink flying. They only come down at night, and only in something like this. Used to be the hollow trees, the big old ones. Then they cut the big old ones.*

A hawk came and sat on the corner of the chimney, a young Cooper's hawk, barred brown, and everybody on the hill booed at it, children and grownups together, a long rolling boo across the whole slope, and Marcus booed loudest. The hawk did not care. It sat there with its shoulders up like a man at a bar and when the wheel of swifts came round it reached up and took one out of the air, quick and ordinary, and flew off with it, and the boo turned into a groan.

Then the wheel tightened. The birds came round and round, lower each time, and the circle narrowed over the mouth of the chimney until it was a funnel, a dark turning funnel of birds pouring into the brick, the

way water goes down a drain, the way smoke goes up a chimney, only backward. It went on for ten minutes. It went on until it was nearly dark, a thick steady pour of them, and the sound of their wings was like wind in dry grass, and then it thinned, and the last few came round once more, a handful, and went in one by one, and the last one hung for a second over the hole and dropped.

The whole hill cheered. The volunteer at the bottom clicked her counter one last time and wrote down a number.

Pavlo had not said anything the whole time. He was sitting with his elbows on his knees, the wool cord around his hand, and Rose saw that his lips had been moving again, and that he was smiling.

Inside, Rose said, *they all hang on the bricks, one on top of the other, like shingles. The bricks keep the heat from the day. In the morning they come out and go eat. Couple days, they're gone south. Mexico, or further. Nobody knows which ones. Nobody follows them.*

They don't carry nothing, Pavlo said.

Nope.

On the walk back down, under the freeway, in the dark, Krystal asked Pavlo what he said when he said the prayer, the words in his language, and he told her, and she tried to say it after him and couldn't, and they both laughed, and he said it again slower.

VI. The Shelf

October

The count at the school went down after the middle of the month. Six thousand. Four thousand. A night in the last week of September with a few hundred. Rose went up on the second of October and sat on the slope a full hour and the sky over the chimney stayed empty, and the volunteer at the bottom put her clicker in her pocket and went home.

On the morning of the fifth Pavlo was gone.

Nobody saw him go. Duane had the gate from two to six that night and swore nobody signed out, and the book bore him out; the last line in

Pavlo's hand was from the afternoon of the fourth, when he had come back from the bakeries with the day-old bread for the shelf. The door of number fourteen was unlocked and open a few inches. The cot was folded. The floor was swept. The blanket and the duffel and the picture of the saint were gone, and the wool cord, and the good shirt off the hook, and the bread knife.

Rose walked up to Twenty-third and asked the young woman with flour in her eyebrows, who said she hadn't seen him since Monday and was he all right, and Rose said she thought so. The old Italian on Twenty-first hadn't seen him either. Rose called the sister in Vancouver, whose number was on Pavlo's intake form, and the sister said he had called her Sunday night, which he did not do often, to say he was well and that she shouldn't worry.

Did he say where he was going?

No, said the sister. *I asked him. He said he would be on the road. He said, tell Rose thank you.*

At the meeting that Tuesday they voted to give number fourteen to a couple who had been on the list since June. Krystal wrote it in the minutes. Shane said he would keep walking up for the day-old bread, and he did, all that winter, two streets, every morning, and came back with it in a laundry bag over his shoulder and put it out on the shelf for anybody.

The white bucket was on the bottom shelf of the kitchen container. Rose found it there the morning he left, washed out and dried and turned upside down on the shelf, the way you leave a thing you are finished with so that nothing can settle in it. There was nothing in it. The strip of blue tape was still on the lid with his name on it in careful capitals, and nobody took it off, and all that winter nobody put anything in it.

Background

The verse

> *Men who have no riches, who live on recognised food, who have perceived void and unconditioned freedom (Nirvana), their path is difficult to understand, like that of birds in the air.*
>
> Dhammapada 92, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Belaṭṭhisīsa finds the daily almsround a bother. He walks one street for alms, eats his breakfast, walks a second street, and carries home plain boiled rice with nothing on it. He dries it and stores it, and then spends several days in meditative absorption, eating the stored rice when he needs to. The other monks are offended and report him to the Buddha, who makes the rule against monks storing food. But because the elder acted before the rule existed, and because he was content with very little, the Buddha declares him blameless and speaks the verse about those who have no stores, whose track is as hard to follow as birds in the sky. The commentary's rice becomes the old Slavic sukhari here, bread sliced and dried hard to keep. Read the full commentary story. The prayer Pavlo says is the Jesus Prayer of the Eastern Orthodox tradition, often counted on a knotted wool prayer rope.

Portland, Oregon

Portland, 2021

From June 26 to 28, 2021, the Pacific Northwest heat wave broke Portland's all-time record three days running: 108°F, then 112°F, then 116°F. TriMet stopped MAX light rail when the overhead wires sagged, and the county opened cooling shelters, among them one at the Oregon Convention Center. Seventy-two of Oregon's confirmed heat deaths were in Multnomah County, most of them in homes without air conditioning or cooled only by fans. Portland's self-governed villages for unhoused people, like Dignity Village, govern themselves, with elected officers and rules of

their own. Rose's school, the Chemawa Indian School near Salem, is the oldest continuously operating Native American boarding school in the United States.

Since the 1980s, migrating Vaux's swifts have roosted each fall in the chimney of Chapman Elementary School in Northwest Portland, often thousands a night. Swifts cannot perch, and they once roosted in large hollow trees, which logging made rare. Portland Audubon's nightly Swift Watch draws crowds of a thousand or more, who boo the hawks that hunt the birds and cheer when the last one goes in. The event was cancelled in 2020 and 2021 to discourage crowds during the pandemic, but volunteers kept counting the swifts, and in 2021 they recorded most nights between two and seven thousand from late August into early October.

After the story of the elder Belaṭṭhisīsa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 92). The original. Scripture from the World English Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7·4

Three Hems

> *The religious life has the robe made of rags taken from a dust heap for its resource.*
> *— Mahāvagga 1:30.4*

Evaṃ me sutaṃ, in the house off Paulding Road.

I. Trash Day

Southeast Fort Wayne, Indiana · October 2003

On Tuesdays, which was trash day on the south side, Thida Win got up at a quarter to six and walked the alleys with U Wimala before the trucks came. Her grandmother had arranged it the spring before, after a woman on Oxford Street called the police about a man in a bedsheet going through her garbage cans, and two officers had stood in the alley for twenty minutes trying to get a seventy-year-old Burmese monk to explain himself in English. Thida was sixteen and a junior at South Side, and her English was better than anyone's at the monastery. That was the whole reason. She hated it.

U Wimala did not ask for food on Tuesdays. The food came to the monastery anyway, every morning, in foil pans and Tupperware, from the eleven families who took turns. On Tuesdays he asked for cloth. He did not ask anybody. He walked down the alleys between Paulding and Pettit with a canvas bag from the public library over his shoulder, and when there was a garbage bag by a fence with something soft showing through a tear, he stopped and looked at it, and if it was cloth that somebody had thrown away he took it. Old sheets. A tablecloth with a burn in the middle. A man's white shirt with one sleeve gone. The bins behind the Goodwill outlet, after the sorting, were good. His eyes were going, and he

went through a bag more with his fingers than his eyes, the way you would read in the dark.

At the monastery he washed what he found in a tub in the back yard and boiled it with chips of Osage orange wood, which he cut himself from the hedgerows out past the airport with a hacksaw. In Sagaing, where he had first been a monk, they had boiled jackfruit heartwood to dye the robes, and he had found out from a library book that the hedge apple tree was a cousin of the jackfruit and gave nearly the same yellow. Then he cut the pieces into panels and sewed them together by hand, sitting on the floor of the garage that was the monastery's hall, and wore them.

The committee had a box of new robes from a supplier in Maryland, factory-made, the right color, in plastic bags. He thanked the committee every year and gave them to the younger monks.

Why can't you wear the new ones? Thida said, the first morning, a little loudly, because a car had slowed down to look at them.

He was untying a knot in a garbage bag with his fingers. He was in no hurry with it. He said that when he was ordained, at fifty-two, the year after his wife died, the preceptor had told him four things, as every monk is told on the day he is ordained, and the second of them was about robes. He said it in Pali, and then in Burmese, and when he saw she was not getting the Burmese he said it once in English, out of a book he had read in the camp in Thailand, word for word, the way he had learned it.

> *The religious life has the robe made of rags taken from a dust heap for its resource. Thus you must endeavour to live all your life. Linen, cotton, silk, woollen garments, coarse cloth, hempen cloth are extra allowances.*
>
> *— Mahāvagga 1:30.4*

Extra allowances, he said. *So the new ones are allowed. But the dust heap is the resource. If you can live on the resource, you live on the resource.*

This is an alley, said Thida.

This is a dust heap, said U Wimala, and got the knot open.

By October of that year his upper robe had been mended so many times that it was more thread than cloth. You could read a newspaper through it. Thida's grandmother, Daw Mya Mya, said at the monastery kitchen sink that if he wore it through the winter he would die of it, and the other women agreed, and nobody said it to him.

II. The Hems

Behind Anthony Boulevard · the last Tuesday in October

The fabric store on Anthony Boulevard had closed in the summer, and its dumpster was still behind it in the alley, with a second dumpster from the shoe repair beyond it. It was barely light. There was frost on the lids.

A woman was standing by the first dumpster as if she were waiting for a bus. She was Burmese, and old-fashioned about it, in a dark silk longyi to her ankles and a short white jacket, with a string of jasmine flowers in her hair, which Thida had not seen on anyone since she was a child in Mae Sot, and which nobody could have bought in Indiana in October. Thida thought she must be somebody's aunt from Chicago. The woman looked at U Wimala, and then at Thida, and smiled at Thida as if they knew each other, and Thida, embarrassed, looked down at her own sneakers. When she looked up the woman was not there. The alley was long and straight in both directions, and there was nobody in it.

U Wimala had not seen her. He was at the second dumpster. He had lifted the lid and was looking at something inside, near the top, on a bed of cardboard.

It was three hems. Three edges of cloth, one above another, folded back so neatly that nothing showed but the hems, each a finger wide, stitched with a stitch so small Thida could not see it until she put her face close. He took hold of the first and pulled. It kept coming. It came out over the edge of the dumpster and down into his arms and onto the frozen gravel, a single length of fine cotton the color of new rice, without a seam or a label or a stain, and when the end came out and they spread it

on the hood of a parked car it was longer than the car, nearly twenty feet, and six feet wide. The second was the same. The third was the same.

U Wimala stood with the third one over his arm and looked into the dumpster at the cardboard, and then at Thida.

This is a very remarkable dust heap, he said.

He folded them himself, carefully, on the hood of the car, and they went into the library bag, all three, which should not have been possible either.

• • •

Thida told her grandmother about the woman that evening, mostly to complain. Daw Mya Mya was cutting onions. She wanted to know about the jacket, what kind of buttons. She wanted to know whether the woman's feet had been on the ground. Thida said she hadn't looked at the woman's feet.

That was his wife, said Daw Mya Mya.

His wife died in Mandalay in 1980, Grandma.

Not that one. Before. Three lives back. She went on cutting onions. *She is with the devas now. In Tāvatiṃsa. Since he was a boy she has been looking after him. You think it is an accident he has never in his life had to say there isn't any? Ask him. Ask him if one day in his life his bowl came back empty.*

Thida did not ask him. But on the next Tuesday she looked at the feet of everyone in the alleys.

III. The Sewing

The garage hall · Saturday, November 8, 2003

THE SAYADAW DECIDED IT IN ONE SENTENCE AT THE MEAL ON Sunday. The cloth would be the kathina robe for that year, and it would go to U Wimala, whose robe was worn out, and it would be sewn the way the kathina robe must be sewn, from cutting to dyeing inside a single day, on the Saturday.

The Sayadaw was seventy-eight. He had been eight years in Insein prison after 1988, and he did not talk about it, except that once, when one

of the boys in the Sunday school could not get a thread through a needle, the Sayadaw took it from him and threaded it in one try without his glasses and said that in Insein you learned to do it by the light from under a door. He came out to the garage on the Saturday before it was light and sat on a cushion at the side, with a cardboard box of needles and a tin of thread, and for the whole of that day every needle in the room came through his hands.

Monks came from two other temples in town, and one from Indianapolis, nineteen monks in all, more than the garage had ever held. U Thuzana, who was older than anyone and kept the rules so strictly that the younger monks were afraid to hand him a cup with the wrong hand, sat at the foot of the cloth. U Pyinnya, who had taught Abhidhamma in Rangoon and could recite the Patthāna for an hour without a book, sat in the middle. At the head sat U Ottama, who was twenty-six and remembered everything anybody had ever said to him, and he laid out the panels.

Thida, who had been sent with a yardstick and a box of chalk, watched him do it. He marked the cloth into long strips and short ones, with seams running down and seams running across, and narrow bands between, so that the robe when it was done would look from above like a patchwork of fields. She said it looked like the soybean stubble out past New Haven when you drove east, all the fields cut up by the fencerows. U Ottama said it was supposed to. He said the Buddha had once stood on a hill and looked down, and he told it to her in English the way he had learned it, as everybody at that monastery seemed to have learned something, out of an old book.

> *'Dost thou perceive, Ananda, how the Magadha rice fields are divided into short pieces, and in rows, and by outside boundaries, and by cross boundaries?'*
>
> *'Even so, Lord.'*
>
> *'Could you, Ananda, provide robes of a like kind for the Bhikkhus?'*
>
> *— Mahāvagga 8:12.1*

The women of the monastery sat along the wall on folding chairs and wound thread from the big cones onto small spools for the monks, and passed the spools down, and when a spool came back empty they wound another. U Kovida, who drove the monastery van and was always going somewhere, went back and forth all day for what was needed: more thread from the Walmart, a second kerosene heater from somebody's basement, pins, coffee, extension cords. Thida went with him on most of the trips because somebody had to go into the stores.

U Wimala sat with the others and sewed his own robe. He said nothing all day about whose it was.

IV. The Telephone

All over the south side

Nobody on the committee had called anybody. Everybody agreed about that afterward.

But starting at about seven that morning, the telephone rang in every Burmese house in Fort Wayne, and there were a great many of those houses by then, and a woman's voice with an old Mandalay accent said: *They are sewing a robe for my U Wimala. The Sayadaw is there, and all the monks from the other temples. Take mohinga. Take rice. Go before eleven.* And hung up. Daw Mya Mya got the call. Thida's English teacher's neighbors got the call, and they were Karen and Baptist. The man who ran the Asian grocery on Calhoun got it twice.

By half past ten there were cars on both sides of the street from Paulding Road to the corner, and on the gravel the city had made the monastery put down over its front lawn, and on the grass of the house next door, whose owner came out in his bathrobe, looked at it, and went back in and came out again with a crockpot of chili. The folding tables went the length of the driveway. Pots of mohinga with the fish broth still steaming, coconut noodles, biryani in hotel pans, tea-leaf salad in mixing bowls, fried gourd fritters in paper towels, sago with coconut milk, three sheet cakes from the Kroger, and rice, rice, rice, in electric cookers on extension cords that ran into the house through the kitchen window.

U Kovida came back from his eleventh errand at a quarter to eleven with a cardboard box on the passenger seat. In it were rose apples, the pink bell-shaped kind that grew over every monastery wall in upper Burma, each one as big as a softball and cold from the night. Nobody knew where he had got them. The Asian grocery on Calhoun said it had never had them in its life. U Kovida, asked, said he had been *a little farther than usual*. They were set out for the monks, one to a monk, and the nineteen monks of three temples and Indianapolis could not finish nineteen rose apples between them, and gave up laughing.

The monks ate before noon, as monks must, and after them the laypeople ate, and the neighbors, and the two police officers who had come about the parking and stayed, and the mailman, and when everybody had eaten there was more food on the tables than there had been when they began.

• • •

The robe was finished in the late afternoon. They boiled it with Osage orange in the biggest rice pot, which took two men to lift, and it came out of the water the color of a yolk and went darker as it cooled. They hung it over a line across the garage between the two heaters to dry.

That evening the moon came up full over the houses along Paulding Road with a dark bite already out of one side, and all evening the bite grew. The children saw it first and shouted, and everyone went out onto the gravel in their coats. A little after eight it was all gone into the shadow, and it did not go out. It went copper, then the red of lac, the old red dye, a deep dull red like an ember, and hung there over the monastery yard, and the whole yard under it, the gravel and the folding tables and the frost on the cars and the faces looking up, was dyed the same red from the street to the back fence. It was very quiet. Even the children stopped.

The old women said afterward, and kept saying for years, that Thagyamin, the king of the devas, had come down that night and drawn a line around the yard. They said you could see where it ran in the frost in the morning. Thida went out at six to look, and there was a line, or there

was the place where the gravel stopped and the neighbor's lawn began, and she could not have said which.

V. Too Much

The garage hall · that night

The visiting monks were offered juice and tea in the garage after the eclipse, which monks may take in the evening, and sat on the floor under the drying robe. Thida was pouring. Two of them were talking in low voices, and she heard it, and so did the Sayadaw.

It is too much. Nineteen monks, and food for three hundred. Look at the tables. Nobody brings this much for a robe.

He has family in Silver Spring. He telephoned them, or they telephoned the whole town. They wanted everybody to see.

Old men like to show how many people they have.

The Sayadaw did not raise his voice. *What are you talking about?*

They told him. They were not ashamed of it; they were older monks and had been at many robe offerings. The Sayadaw asked whether they really thought U Wimala had sent for all this.

Yes, Sayadaw. We think so.

My son Wimala does not talk like that, said the Sayadaw. *A monk who is finished does not spend his breath on robes and rice. He has not asked anybody for anything since I have known him. Not even in the alley.* He looked up at the robe hanging over them, the color of a yolk, not quite dry. *This was not ordered. A devi brought this. You were all here. You ate it.*

Nobody said anything. U Wimala, at the end of the row, had his eyes closed. Thida could not tell whether he had heard any of it.

VI. Up

Paulding Road · Sunday, November 9

They offered the robe in the morning. The laypeople passed it from hand to hand down the length of the garage, everyone touching it, and the monks gave it to U Wimala in the old formula, and

HE PUT IT ON. IT FIT AS IF IT HAD GROWN ON HIM. HIS OLD UPper robe, the one you could read a newspaper through, he folded and gave to Thida's grandmother, who cut it into squares that winter and put one in the wallet of every grandchild.

There was still food on the tables. U Kovida and Thida drove it in the van all afternoon, foil pan after foil pan, to the Rescue Mission downtown and to the apartment complexes off Hessen Cassel Road where the newest families lived, and to the house on Oxford Street whose owner had called the police on U Wimala, who stood in her doorway holding a pan of biryani and did not know what to say.

When they got back the Sayadaw was standing in the gravel with his hands behind his back, looking up. Thida heard it before she saw it, a far, rolling, rattling sound like wooden wheels on a bridge, and then she found them, very high, a long loose line of big gray birds going south over Paulding Road, hundreds, calling the whole way.

Cranes, said U Kovida.

The Sayadaw watched them go. Then he said, to nobody in particular, or to Thida, since she was the one beside him: *Now show me where they went.*

She looked. They were over the airport, and then they were over the hedgerows, and then they were a thread, and then there was the sky over Paulding Road, the whole cold blue of it, with nothing in it anywhere to say which way they had gone.

U Wimala was already in the alley with the library bag. It was not Tuesday. He did not seem to be looking for anything. She watched him to the corner in the new robe, the color of the hedge-apple trees in October, and then she watched the corner.

Background

The verse

> *He whose appetites are stilled, who is not absorbed in enjoyment, who has perceived void and unconditioned freedom (Nirvana), his path is difficult to understand, like that of birds in the air.*
>
> Dhammapada 93, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Anuruddha, whose robes are worn out, goes looking for cast-off cloth on refuse heaps. A goddess named Jālinī, who had been his wife three lives before, lays three heavenly cloths on a heap ahead of him so that only the hems show, and he pulls them out, remarking what a remarkable refuse heap it is. On the sewing day the Buddha and the great disciples all take part: Mahā Kassapa sits at the foot, Sāriputta in the middle, Ānanda at the head, the monks spin thread, the Buddha threads the needle, and Mahā Moggallāna fetches what is needed and brings great rose-apples. The goddess goes through the village urging everyone to bring food; Sakka draws a circle round the place and the ground turns red as lac; and far more food is left over than the monks can eat. Some monks grumble that Anuruddha must have sent for his relatives to show how many supporters he has, and the Buddha answers that one whose defilements are gone does not talk about requisites, and that a deity brought the food. Read the full commentary story, or about Anuruddha.

Fort Wayne, Indiana

Fort Wayne, 2003

Burmese settlement in Fort Wayne, Indiana, began with a small group of student exiles from the 1988 democracy uprising, sponsored by local churches; hundreds more followed, and for years the city was among the most common resettlement destinations for refugees from Burma. By 2007 a local paper counted between 2,000 and 3,000 Burmese and more than 500 Mon in the city, and six Buddhist temples had

opened in a dozen years, several of them in ordinary houses on the south side, where neighbors complained about cars parked on the lawns and the city required a house temple to gravel its yard.

The Kathina ceremony, held in the month after the rains retreat, is the offering of robe cloth to the monastic community; in Burma the season coincides with the Tazaungdaing festival, when weavers compete through the night to finish robes by dawn. Monks' robes in Burma were once dyed with jackfruit heartwood; the Osage orange of Midwestern hedgerows is a relative in the same genus of dye trees and gives a similar yellow. On the night of November 8, 2003, a total lunar eclipse was visible across the Americas in the evening, the moon turning a deep red.

After the story of the Elder Anuruddha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 93). The original. Scripture from the Mahāvagga in *Vinaya Texts*, tr. T. W. Rhys Davids and Hermann Oldenberg, Sacred Books of the East 13 and 17 (1881–82). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7·5

The Slow Ascent

> *And let the figure be composite—a pair of winged horses and a charioteer.*
> *— Plato, Phaedrus*

Étsi to ákousa, on the sponge docks.

I. The Third Pew

Tarpon Springs, Florida · January 1936

EVERY YEAR FROM CHRISTMAS UNTIL THE EPIPHANY THE sponge boats stayed in. They lay along the river two and three deep with their masts bare, painted fresh white and blue for the holy day, and the divers who had been out since spring sat in the coffeehouses on the docks with their worry beads and their backgammon boards and told one another the same stories about the bottom.

Every year in those twelve days, at some hour nobody saw, Barba Nikitas came back.

He had dived for forty-three years, from the islands to Benghazi to the Gulf of Mexico, and he had never once had the bends. People on the docks said it the way they said a man had never once been drunk: as a fact, and a little uneasily. He had been born on Kalymnos in 1872 and gone down in the suit for the first time at sixteen, off the coast of Africa, in water so deep the light at the bottom was the color of a bruise, and in his first season four men on his boat came up paralyzed and two of them died. In Florida the beds were shallower and the bends came less often, but they came. Men came up too fast with their bags full and lay on the deck with their legs gone dead under them, and some walked again and some never did. Barba Nikitas had come up slow every time. A fathom,

and stop, and breathe. A fathom, and stop. However many sponges he left lying on the bottom, however the captain swore at him down the line. He said the sponges would be there tomorrow and the captain might find another diver if he liked. The captains swore at him for forty-three years and never found a better one.

When his wife died in 1931 he quit diving and went to live with his daughter in Jacksonville, where her husband had a restaurant. That was two hundred miles away. He came back every January on the train. He stayed at the Kalymnian boardinghouse by the river, and he sat on the Epiphany at the end of the third pew on the men's side in St. Nicholas, by the window, and on the day after he was gone again.

Nobody ever sat in that place on the Epiphany. Nobody had decided it. Nobody would have known who to ask.

Kyr Lefteris Mavrikos had been a schoolmaster on Kalymnos before the war, before the Italians, before his own three sons came across one after another to dive and he came after them to see that they did not die of it. He was nearly seventy. He clipped sponges at the Exchange, standing all day at a plank table in a canvas apron with a pair of long shears, cutting off the dead black roots and trimming each sponge round, and in the afternoons when the American school let out he taught the children their letters at the same table, with the shears put away and the sponges pushed to one end. He spoke very little. He made the children say every word back to him until they had it, and then he made them take it apart.

That week he was teaching them *ἡνίοχος.* The one who drives the chariot.

Ἡνία, he said. The reins. *Ἔχω.* I hold.

The one who holds the reins, said the children.

Good. Again.

On the second of January a letter came to the boardinghouse from Jacksonville in Barba Nikitas's square careful hand. His daughter was near her time with her fourth, and the doctor did not like the look of it, and he would not leave her. He would light a candle at home. He sent his respects to the priests and to the bishop who would be coming, and five dollars for the boys who dived.

The landlady read it out in the kitchen. By evening everybody on the docks knew. The divers said it was a pity. Kyr Lefteris said nothing at all and went on clipping.

II. The Basil

January 6, 1936

THE BISHOP CAME DOWN ON THE TRAIN FROM THE NORTH THE evening before, with two deacons and a protopsaltis and a young man who carried his bags and his staff, and the whole town met the train. There had been a band. There were policemen to hold the crowd back and the mayor in a gray overcoat and two men from the Florida newspapers. In the morning the church was so full that people stood in the street outside the open doors and listened to the Liturgy through them, and the smoke of the censers drifted out over their heads into the sun.

After the Liturgy the bishop blessed the water in the churchyard. He stood over the great basin in his gold vestments with the deacons on either side of him and dipped the cross three times, and then he took up a thick bunch of basil from the tray they held for him and began to sprinkle the people. *Vasilikós,* the women called it, the royal herb. The smell of it went up green and sharp in the cold sunshine. The people pressed forward with their bottles and jars to carry the water home.

He came back into the church to sprinkle the pews. He went down the aisle on the men's side, scattering water right and left, and at the third pew he stopped.

Afterward people argued about exactly what he said. Some said he only asked, *Where is the old diver who comes from Jacksonville?* The protopsaltis, who was standing nearest, said the bishop had heard about Barba Nikitas on the train the night before, from the president of the community, and that what he said was, *I would have liked to see that man.*

Then he looked down at the end of the pew by the window, and Barba Nikitas was sitting there.

He was in his black suit and his white shirt buttoned to the throat without a tie, the way he always came. His hands were folded on his

knees, big and spotted and quiet. Forty people saw him. The men on either side of him moved apart as if they had been pushed, and one of them crossed himself three times. Nobody had seen him come in. The church had been full since six, with the doors jammed and people standing in the street.

The bishop did not seem surprised. He dipped the basil and sprinkled the old man's head and his folded hands, and then he did a thing the community talked about for forty years. He gave him the whole bunch of basil, wet, into his hands. And then he bowed to him, from the waist, the way you bow to an icon.

Barba Nikitas stood up and bowed back. He did not say anything. He sat down again with the basil in his lap.

At noon he walked in the procession to Spring Bayou with the other old divers, behind the children of the Greek school in their island costumes. He stood at the rail while the bishop went out on the barge to the middle of the bayou and the dove went up, white, with its blue ribbon, out of a girl's hands, and the cross went into the water and thirty boys went in after it. He was seen at the blessing of the boats in the afternoon. After that nobody saw him. The landlady at the boardinghouse said he had not slept there. The conductor on the Jacksonville train, who was a Methodist and had no reason to lie, said that no old Greek gentleman in a black suit had ridden with him either way that week.

The letter from his daughter came on the fourteenth. It was a girl, and they were both well. Her father sent his love to everybody. He had not been out of the house since Christmas. He had spent the Epiphany morning in a chair by the kitchen window with his eyes shut, she wrote, and when she asked him if he was sleeping, he said no, he was at church.

III. The Clipping Table

The Sponge Exchange · that week

THE GRUMBLING STARTED AT THE GLENDI AND WENT ON through the week at the coffeehouses, and by Thursday it had reached the Exchange.

He bowed to him, said Captain Fotis Kambouris, who owned four boats. He was standing at Kyr Lefteris's table with the president of the community and old Papa Dimitris's son-in-law, who sat on the parish council. *A bishop. To a diver who has not brought up a sponge since Hoover.*

He did not bow to Papa Dimitris, said the son-in-law, *who has served this parish twenty years.*

He did not bow to the president, said the captain. *Who met him at the train. Who paid for the band.*

The president said nothing, but he did not say they were wrong.

Kyr Lefteris finished the sponge he was trimming and set it with the others and laid the shears down. The children were coming along the dock with their slates for the afternoon lesson, and he waited for them to come up and stand around the end of the table before he spoke.

Captain, he said, *how many men have you seen come up with the bends?*

The captain told him. It was a long number. He knew all their names.

And how many times did Nikitas come up too fast?

Never. The captain shrugged. *Everybody knows that. He came up like a man climbing stairs in church. It cost me a thousand dollars a season.*

Did he ever take a drink at the glendi?

No.

Did he ever play cards for money on the boat? Did he ever pick a fight? Did he ever tell you how good a diver he was?

The captain did not answer, because the answer was no and everybody at the table knew it. Barba Nikitas had never said one word about himself in forty-three years that anybody could remember. He went down and he came up, slow, and he ate what the cook gave him, and he slept.

Forty-three years he was on the bottom, said Kyr Lefteris, *where a man sees more sponges than he can carry and the whole sea is pulling him up toward the light, and every time he stopped at the fathom. Every time.* He touched the shears on the table without picking them up. *You want to know why the bishop bowed. Bishops are men. They have wanted things all their lives and gone up too fast. When they see a man who holds his own reins they cannot help themselves.*

He turned to the children.

What did we learn this week?

Ἡνίοχος, they said. *The one who holds the reins.*

Good. He took a little book out of the pocket of his apron, worn soft, a Plato in Greek that he had carried from the island, and opened it to a place he did not need to look for, and read it to them slowly in the old language, which the captain, who had left school at nine to dive, followed the way a man follows a boat in fog.

> *The right-hand horse is upright and cleanly made; he has a lofty neck and an aquiline nose; his colour is white, and his eyes dark; he is a lover of honour and modesty and temperance, and the follower of true glory; he needs no touch of the whip, but is guided by word and admonition only.*
>
> *— Plato, Phaedrus 253d, tr. Benjamin Jowett*

Guided by word, Kyr Lefteris said again in plain Greek, for the captain, and shut the book. *Not the whip. Only the word. That is a horse the gods would want to drive.*

The captain stood a while longer. Then he went off down the dock toward his boats, and the president went with him, and the son-in-law, and the children sat down on the planks with their slates.

IV. The Fathom

The Gulf · spring 1936

The boats sailed on the eleventh of January. Captain Fotis's best boat had a new diver that season, a boy from Pothia nineteen years old, the same one who had come up out of Spring Bayou with the cross in his teeth on the Epiphany and been carried through the streets on the other boys' shoulders.

On his first day on the bottom, forty miles out, the boy filled his bag in an hour and felt the tug on the line, the signal to come up. He started up hand over hand, fast, the way they all did, the way the light pulled you. Then at the first fathom he stopped, without knowing why, and hung

there in the green water and breathed. He thought of an old man in a black suit with a wet bunch of basil in his lap.

He came up the rest of the way a fathom at a time. On the deck the captain was standing over the air hose with his face dark, ready to swear at him, and did not.

Back in town the landlady had found the basil on the windowsill of the room where Barba Nikitas had not slept, dried and tied with a bit of white thread. She hung it on a nail over the third pew on the men's side, and it stayed there, gray and sweet, until the parish moved into the new church with the dome in 1943 and the old pews were carried out.

Background

The verse

> *The gods even envy him whose senses, like horses well broken in by the driver, have been subdued, who is free from pride, and free from appetites.*
>
> Dhammapada 94, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Kaccāyana lives far off in Avanti but travels often to hear the Buddha, and at the great Invitation ceremony at the end of the rains the other elders always leave his seat empty for him. Sakka, king of the gods, comes with his retinue bearing perfumes and garlands, notices the empty seat and wishes the elder were there, and at once Kaccāyana is sitting in it. Sakka greets him warmly, honors him with perfumes and flowers and bows to him. Some of the monks complain that Sakka has favored one elder over the others, and the Buddha answers that those who guard the doors of their senses as Kaccāyana does are dear to gods and men alike. Kaccāyana is remembered as the disciple best at drawing out the full meaning of a short saying, and Pali tradition credits him with its first grammar. Read the full commentary story.

Tarpon Springs, Florida

Tarpon Springs, *1936*

Sponges had been hooked from small boats off Tarpon Springs since the 1880s. In 1905 John Cocoris brought over divers and crews from Greece who worked the beds in the heavy diving suit, and before long most of them came from the Dodecanese islands of Kalymnos, Symi and Halki, which Italy ruled from 1912 until after the Second World War. In the Mediterranean the suit had killed and paralyzed divers by the thousands; the man who helped design it advised coming up at about three feet a minute, and divers trained in breath-hold diving rarely did. The Gulf beds were shallower and kinder, but the bends still came, and in one history of the sponge divers an old diver says that the careful ones, who resist greed, can dive happily all their lives.

The town's Greeks have kept the Epiphany, or Theophany, since 1903. The sponge boats stayed in port from Christmas until that day. After the Liturgy at St. Nicholas the presiding bishop blessed the water, and people carried it home with sprigs of basil; at noon a procession went down to Spring Bayou, a white dove was released, the bishop threw a cross into the water from a barge, and young men dove for it. The boats were blessed in the afternoon and the day ended in a glendi. The congregation moved into its present domed church in 1943. The teacher's lesson is the image from Plato's *Phaedrus* of the soul as a charioteer with two horses, one wild and one that needs no whip; the Greek word for the driver, *hēníochos*, means the one who holds the reins.

After the story of the Elder Mahā Kaccāyana from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 94). The original. Text from Plato's *Phaedrus*, translated by Benjamin Jowett. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7.6

The Doorsill

Let him put his mouth in the dust,
If so be there may be hope.
— Lamentations 3:29

The way I got it, in the pines at Yaphank.

I. The Names

Camp Upton, Yaphank, Long Island · September 1917

First Sergeant Andrew Fedorko had the names in four days.

The company came down from the city on the Long Island Rail Road with tags on their coats, two hundred and fifty of them, and stood in the sand between the stumps while the carpenters were still nailing the roof on their barracks. There were bookkeepers and iceman's helpers, a pastry cook from the Hotel Astor, a Chinese laundryman's son from Mott Street, a boy who had sung in the choir at the Eldridge Street synagogue, two brothers who drove a moving van in Hell's Kitchen and fought each other every night until the Top separated them by a whole floor. Italians from Mulberry Bend and Italians from Bensonhurst who did not think of each other as the same thing. Irish from Chelsea. Swedes from Bay Ridge. Poles, Armenians, a Norwegian sailor who had jumped ship in 1912, an Albanian, three Greeks who ran a lunchroom together on Eighth Avenue and had been drafted on the same morning.

The other sergeants called the roll the way you push a wheelbarrow over roots. They stopped at every third name, swore, spelled it, guessed. Fedorko did not stop. He said Kowalczyk and Esposito and Der Bedrossi-

an and Lindqvist and Moskowitz as if he had grown up next door to every one of them, and in a way he had.

He was thirty-eight that fall. He had come over from Šariš at four in the steerage of a ship he did not remember and grown up in a patch outside Shenandoah, in the hard coal, in a company house with a cow in the back and the Greek Catholic church on Chestnut Street at the end of the world. At nine he went into the breaker. He sat on a board over the chute all day picking slate out of the running coal, with Lithuanian boys on one side of him and Polish boys on the other and an Irish boss behind with a stick, and the names of everything in four languages went into him through the dust. At twenty he walked to Pottsville and enlisted. He had been in the Philippines, and in China for a summer, and on the Mexican border the year before. He had eighteen years in. The Army had sent him to Yaphank with a handful of other old Regulars to make soldiers out of New York, and he had a voice like a breaker whistle and a way of saying a man's name that made the man stand straighter.

The captain was a lawyer named Halpern, from Henry Street, who had gone through the officers' camp at Plattsburg and come out with two silver bars and a cough. He was thirty-four. He did not raise his voice, and he did not say much of anything. On the corner of his desk in the orderly room he kept a new black Bible, the translation the Jewish Publication Society had brought out that very year, and when the company clerk dusted the desk he dusted around it.

There was one name Fedorko did not need to learn, because nobody used it.

Jonas Kazlauskas was a cabinetmaker's helper from Williamsburg, twenty-two, short and fair and quiet, with a cowlick he wet down every morning and every morning lost. On his first day a corporal had looked at the tag on his coat and said, *What is that, Cassidy?* and Cassidy he became. He answered to it. He answered to Hey You and Blondie and the Swede, though he was not a Swede. He did his drill and cleaned his rifle and wrote his mother on Sundays at the Y.M.C.A. hut, in Lithuanian, and nobody in the company had ever heard him laugh out loud.

When the Top called the roll in the dark at a quarter to six, he said Kazlauskas like the rest, correctly, with the weight in the right place. But the roll was the roll. Kazlauskas waited for something else, without knowing exactly what it was.

II. Russian Christmas

The company street · Saturday, January 5, 1918

The winter came down on Long Island early and stayed. By Christmas the sand was frozen like cement and the wind off the Sound came through the board walls of the barracks as if there were no walls. In the city there was no coal. People stood in line with baby carriages to buy it by the pail. At Upton the stoves were red all night and the men slept in their overcoats anyway.

Fedorko had not taken a furlough in four years. On the first of January the captain called him into the orderly room and said, *Your people keep Christmas on the seventh.*

Yes, sir. The old calendar.

Go home for it.

The company, sir.

Go home, Sergeant.

That was a long speech, for Halpern.

So on the Saturday morning before the Holy Supper, Fedorko came out of the barracks in his overcoat with a barracks bag over his shoulder, to walk to the station and take the train to the city, and the ferry over to Jersey City, and the train from there into the coal country. In his bag he had a pound of honey from the canteen for his mother, a wool scarf for his brother's girl, and a German helmet spike a sergeant in the 305th had swapped him for a pocketknife, for his nephew.

He had meant to slip out. He did not get the chance. Somebody in the kitchen had told somebody, and by the time he came down the stairs the company was out on the frozen street in their overcoats, without being told, in no kind of order, to see him off.

He went down the line of them shaking hands. He did it the way he called the roll, every name, every man, with the weight in the right place. *Esposito. Go easy on the sugar. Lindqvist. Shave. Moskowitz, if you write that girl one more poem she'll marry the iceman.* They laughed and stamped their feet and their breath went up white. The Hell's Kitchen brothers stood together for once. The choirboy from Eldridge Street gave him a cake his mother had sent, wrapped in a newspaper, for the train.

Kazlauskas was at the back by the woodpile. He had been there first. He was in the second row, then the third, as men pushed in front of him, and by the time Fedorko reached his part of the street there were six big men between them, and Fedorko said *Keogh* and *Russo* and *Der Bedrossian* and then he was past, still shaking hands, still saying names, on toward the end of the street.

Kazlauskas thought, *He said everybody's but mine.*

He moved along the back of the crowd to get ahead of it, to the corner where the street met the road to the station, so that the Top would have to pass him there. He stood with his hands in his pockets. The Top came on, finishing up with the last of them, and turned the corner fast, because the train would not wait, swinging his barracks bag from one shoulder to the other as he turned, and the long end of his wool muffler, stiff with frost, flew out and caught Kazlauskas across the ear, not hard, the way a wet towel slaps, and the Top kept going down the road toward the station with his barracks bag on his shoulder and did not look back.

Kazlauskas stood there with his ear stinging.

He waited until the Top was a small brown figure going down past the base hospital. Then he went to the orderly room and knocked and stood at attention in front of the captain's desk.

Sir, I want to report the first sergeant.

The captain looked up.

He hit me, sir. Back there on the street, in front of everybody. On the side of my head. My ear's still ringing. He says, I'm the Top, and he hits me, and he walks off to the train without a word.

Halpern looked at him for a while. Then he said to the clerk, *Abramowitz. Take the Ford. Go to the station and ask the first sergeant to come back.*

III. The Keys

Barracks and mess hall · eleven o'clock

Corporal Sol Abramowitz, the company clerk, drove the Ford down to the station and found the Top on the platform with the cake under his arm, stamping his feet. He told him. The Top did not say anything. He picked up his bag and got in the Ford, and they drove back past the train coming in.

By then Sergeant Pat Keogh had heard it.

Keogh was the supply sergeant, a structural ironworker from Chelsea who had walked the beams of the Woolworth Building, six foot three, and he loved the Top the way a younger brother does who would never say so. He found Abramowitz in the orderly room. Abramowitz had the keys. He always had the keys. He knew where everything in the company was, every blanket and spoon and every man's next of kin, and he could tell you without looking what the Top had said to the colonel on the eleventh of October.

Cassidy says the Top hit him, said Keogh.

I know.

The Top never hit a man in his life that didn't hit him first.

I know.

The captain don't know the Top like we do. Keogh put out his hand for the keys. *Get everybody in the mess hall. He's going to give it to that kid with both barrels, and I want them all there when he does.*

So they went through the barracks, the two of them, upstairs and down, and the barracks next door where the company's overflow slept. Abramowitz unlocked the supply room and the drying room and the latrine door, which stuck. Keogh banged on the bunks with his fist. *Mess hall! Everybody! Come on, come on, come on! The Top's back, and he's going to let Cassidy have it! You want to see something, come on!* They pulled men out of the card games and out of the washroom with lather on their faces and out of their blankets, men who had been on guard all night, and they brought them all down the frozen street into the mess hall, two hundred and forty-some men in overcoats, and stood them in among the tables,

and more sat on the tables, and the cooks came out of the kitchen with their arms folded.

The captain came in and sat at the end of the officers' table under the flag. Kazlauskas stood near him, white. The lieutenants stood. Then the door opened and the Top came in and took off his campaign hat and stood where the captain pointed.

It was so quiet you could hear the coffee tick in the urn.

Sergeant, the captain said. *Private Kazlauskas says you struck him on the street this morning, on the head, and went on without a word. What do you say?*

Keogh leaned forward on his table, waiting for it.

IV. Nine Things

The mess hall · noon

The Top looked at the floor a while. He did not look at Kazlauskas.

Sir, he said. *A man who doesn't keep his own body in his eye, he might knock against another man and go off and never know it. Never say he was sorry. That could be.*

He stopped. Then he went on, slowly, the way he talked on the rifle range when a man was afraid of his piece.

Sir, this ground here. They dig latrines in it. They bury the garbage in it. They plant the flagpole in it and they bury the dead in it. The ground doesn't care. It doesn't say, this is clean, I like it, this is dirty, I don't. I try to be like that.

Water. The wash rack. Same water washes the officers' cups and the grease trap. It doesn't mind.

The stove. You put in coal, you put in letters, you put in rags with lice in them. It burns them. It doesn't ask which.

The wind off the Sound. It blows on the colonel's quarters and it blows on the latrines. It doesn't pick.

The kitchen rag. He nodded at the cooks. *Russo wipes the captain's table with it, he wipes up what the dog did. The rag doesn't get proud. Doesn't get ashamed. I try to be like the rag.*

Somebody near the kitchen door made a small sound.

When I was a kid, the Top said, *in the breaker, we used to go up into the English town on Saturday, the Welsh town. Up on the hill. We were Hunkies. You know what that means, some of you. A Hunky kid goes up that hill with his cap in his hand, and he walks small, and he don't ask for nothing, and he don't look at nobody, and he goes home. I try to walk like that kid. All the time. Even now. With these.* He touched the diamond on his sleeve. *Especially now.*

At home we had a cow that the old man sawed the horns off. She'd walk up and down the patch, in and out of every yard, and the little kids would hang on her and she never hooked one of them. I try to be like that cow.

He was quiet a little. Then he said:

Sir, you know how some fellows, they're particular. They take a bath every day, they put on the hair oil, they want their shirt just so. You hang a dead dog around a fellow like that's neck, that's been in the road three days, he'll go crazy trying to get it off. That's how I feel about this, mostly. He touched his own chest with two fingers. *This body. It's a dead dog they tied on me. I carry it because I got to.*

And I carry it careful. Like the old man's dinner pail, when it rusted out. It had holes in the bottom. The lard came out the holes. He carried it down the shaft anyway because he didn't have another, and he carried it careful, both hands, so as not to lose any more than he had to. That's me, sir. A pail with holes in it. Carrying it careful. A man like that, sir, how is he going to go and hit somebody?

That was all he said.

The men who were there told it afterward in different ways, and in some of the ways there were more words, and in some fewer. But all of them told it the same about the floor. While he spoke, the floor of the mess hall shook. It shuddered up from under, from the sand, the way it had in the fall when the engineers were blowing stumps. It shook nine times, once at the end of each thing he said, and nine times the coffee in the big urn rang like a bell, and nine times the stovepipe ticked in its collar, and one of the cooks put his hand flat on the wall. There was no blasting that day. It was a Saturday, and the ground was frozen two feet down, and the engineers were all in Patchogue at the pictures.

When he got to the Hunky kid with his cap in his hand, the pastry cook from the Astor started crying and could not stop. When he got to the rag, two of the Italians did, and Lindqvist, who had never been seen to have a feeling of any kind. At the pail with holes in it a good part of the company was crying, the way men cry who have not done it in a long time, with their shoulders, looking at the floor. Keogh was not crying. Keogh sat on his table with his big hands open on his knees and his mouth a little open, and he had the look on his face that he had told Abramowitz once a man gets on a beam forty floors up when he looks down for the first time and finds out he isn't afraid.

V. The Floor

The mess hall · afternoon

Jonas Kazlauskas stood by the officers' table. All the time the Top was talking, he felt it come up through him from his feet, the way the shudder came up through the floor. It came up into his knees and his stomach and his chest and into his face, where the ear had stopped stinging an hour ago, and when the Top said *a pail with holes in it* it reached the top of his head, and he went down on the floor in front of the captain's table on both knees.

He never hit me, he said. *Sir. He never touched me. It was his muffler. It was the end of his muffler in the wind. He didn't say my name. That's all. Everybody's but mine. I made it up. I'm a liar, sir. Put me in the guardhouse.*

Nobody moved.

The captain looked down at him a long moment. Then he looked at the Top and said, quietly, in the voice he used for everything:

Sergeant. Let him off. Before his head comes apart.

And the Top came across the mess hall floor between the tables. Men moved their feet out of his way. He came to where Kazlauskas was kneeling, and he did not stand over him. He went down on his heels in front of him, the way men squat at the mouth of a mine waiting for the cage, so that their faces were on a level. He put his two hands together in front of him with the palms flat, the way the old women did at the Greek Catholic

church on Chestnut Street when the priest came out with the cup, and held them out toward the boy.

Kazlauskas, he said, with the weight in the right place. *Jonas. It's nothing. I let you off. Now you let me off. If I did anything to you, any time, that I don't know about, you let me off for it. All right?*

Kazlauskas looked at the two flat hands in front of his face. He did not know what to do with them. After a while he put his own hands around them, and they stayed like that, the two of them on the mess hall floor, and the coffee urn ticked.

Afterward, at the tables, the men could not leave it alone. *Did you see that? The kid lies on him in front of the whole company and he gets down on the floor and asks the kid's pardon. I'd have broke his neck. My old man would've broke his neck and then asked the priest. There's nothing in him. You can't get a hook into him. There's no place to hang it.*

Halpern had not left. He stood up at the end of the officers' table, and the talk stopped.

What are you all talking about?

They told him.

He nodded slowly, as if it were a case he had already read.

He can't hold it, the captain said. *Not men like him. There's nothing in him to hold it with. He's like the ground out there. Like the sill of that door, that every one of you walks over twenty times a day. Like the lake down at Yaphank where the river comes up out of the sand, that you can see the bottom of in January.*

He picked up the black Bible from the table, where he had carried it in, and he did not open it. He knew it.

> *They that trust in the LORD*
> *Are as mount Zion, which cannot be moved, but abideth for ever.*
>
> *— Psalm 125:1*

Then he looked at his watch and said, *Sergeant Fedorko, there's a train at four-ten,* and went back to the orderly room.

That evening Abramowitz, sweeping up, found the captain's Bible left open on the desk at a page near the back, with a pencil line in the margin beside three verses. He read them standing up, with the broom in his other hand. He had been raised on the Hebrew and had not thought much about what it said in English.

> *Let him sit alone and keep silence,*
> *Because He hath laid it upon him.*
> *Let him put his mouth in the dust,*
> *If so be there may be hope.*
> *Let him give his cheek to him that smiteth him,*
> *Let him be filled full with reproach.*
>
> *— Lamentations 3:28–30*

He closed the book and put it back square on the corner of the desk, and dusted around it.

VI. Holy Supper

Shenandoah, Pennsylvania · the night of January 6

He missed the Saturday connections at Jersey City and slept on a bench in the terminal at Jersey City and came up into the coal country on Sunday afternoon on the slow train, through Tamaqua and Mahanoy, past the black hills of culm with smoke coming out of their sides where they had been burning for years, past the breakers standing up over the patches like churches, with their windows lit.

There was coal here. There was coal everywhere, in heaps along the tracks, in the yards, in the gutters. In New York people were standing in line with baby carriages, and here the children were throwing it at each other.

He got off at Shenandoah after dark and walked out to the patch with his bag. The snow was grey with dust. It was the old Christmas Eve, and the first star was out, and in every company house along the row there was one candle in the window.

His mother had set the table and waited and given him up and set his place anyway. That was the custom. You set a place for the ones who were not there, the dead and the far away and the stranger who might come. There was straw under the tablecloth, from the cow's shed, and a loaf on the straw and a bowl of honey and a head of garlic. There was the mushroom soup and the sauerkraut and the little dough balls with poppy seed and honey, and the bobal'ki had gone cold, and his brother had eaten his share of the pirohy and said so.

His mother looked at him a long time in the doorway. She was small and bent and her hands were black in the creases, from fifty years of the dust, though she scrubbed them every day of her life.

*Christos ražd*ajetsja,* she said.

Slavite Jeho.

She dipped a clove of garlic in the honey and made the cross on his forehead with it, the way she had done every Christmas Eve when he was a boy coming home from the breaker, and it was sticky and smelled of garlic and he stood still for it, bent down, with his hat in his hands.

You're late, she said. *What kept you?*

He thought about it.

A boy in the company, he said. *I forgot to say goodbye to him.*

He took off his overcoat and his muffler and hung them on the nail by the door. The end of the muffler was still stiff with the Long Island frost, and as it warmed in the kitchen it began, very slowly, to drip on the floor.

VII. The Sill

Cherry Grove, Fire Island · 1938

They went to France in April. Of what happened there to the company, to the Top and Keogh and Abramowitz and the Hell's Kitchen brothers and the pastry cook and the captain with the cough, some of it is written down in the regimental history and some of it is not written anywhere. Jonas Kazlauskas came home in the spring of 1919 with a piece of a German shell in his hip that the doctors said to leave where it was. He went back to cabinetmaking. He married a girl from his

own church in Williamsburg and they had four children, and the first boy they named Andrew, and when people asked why, he said it was after a man he knew in the Army, and did not say any more.

The war ended, and the Army sold off the camp at Yaphank, the buildings and the stoves and the bunks. Some of the barracks were knocked down and carried across the bay to Fire Island, and the boards went into the first cottages at Cherry Grove, where people from the city came for the summer to swim and be left alone.

In the summer of 1938, a few weeks before the hurricane, Kazlauskas was hired to hang new doors on one of those cottages, and the old sill he took out from under the kitchen door was a length of yellow pine with a number stenciled on the underside in Army paint. He turned it over in his hands. Along the top, a little left of the middle, where a man coming out a door would stand still for a moment and plant himself, the grain was worn down into a smooth hollow, the size and shape of a right shoe.

He did not throw it out. He sanded the rest of it down and oiled it and put it back under the new door, the hollow and all, and the woman who owned the cottage asked him why he had not planed it flat.

People should walk on it, he said.

Background

The verse

> *Such a one who does his duty is tolerant like the earth, like Indra's bolt; he is like a lake without mud; no new births are in store for him.*
>
> Dhammapada 95, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Sāriputta, the Buddha's chief disciple, takes leave of the monks at the end of the rains and greets each by his personal and family name, but in the crowd he overlooks one obscure monk, and the hem of his robe brushes against him. The monk tells the Buddha that Sāriputta struck him and went off without asking pardon. Moggallāna and Ānanda, sure their elder brother will "roar a lion's roar," go from cell to cell with the keys and call the whole community together. Sāriputta does not deny the charge. He describes his own mind in nine plain similes (the earth, water, fire and wind that take clean and unclean alike, a dust-rag, an out-

caste boy entering a village, a bull with its horns cut, a body felt like a carcass hung round the neck, and a body carried like a leaking pot of fat), and the earth shakes nine times. The accuser confesses; Sāriputta crouches before him with joined hands and asks his pardon in return; and the Buddha says his mind is like the earth, a threshold-post and a still pool. The similes are those of the Sīhanāda Sutta, Anguttara Nikāya 9.11. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.

Camp Upton, New York

Camp Upton, 1917–18

Camp Upton was built in the scrub-oak barrens near Yaphank in the summer of 1917, and the first drafted men arrived in September, when the camp was far from finished; they helped build it, while engineers blasted the stumps from the drill grounds. The 77th Division organized there was made of draftees from New York City, men of some twenty-five nationalities, and it took the Statue of Liberty for its shoulder patch. Experienced Regular Army officers and noncommissioned officers were sent to the new National Army camps to train them. One company's own account, Company B, 307th Infantry (1920), describes two-story barracks with kitchen and mess hall below and bunks above, straw mattresses, and drill, drill, drill. The division paraded down Fifth Avenue on Washington's Birthday, 1918, and sailed for France that April. After the war many of the camp's buildings were taken across the bay to become the first cottages of Cherry Grove on Fire Island.

The winter of 1917–18 brought a coal famine in the eastern cities, and the Fuel Administration answered with price controls, shortened factory weeks and "heatless Mondays." Most of that coal came from the anthracite fields of eastern Pennsylvania, where tens of thousands of Carpatho-Rusyn, Slovak, Polish and Lithuanian immigrants worked, and where boys as young as eight or nine sat over the chutes as breaker boys, picking slate from the coal. St. Michael's in Shenandoah, founded in 1884, was the first Greek Catholic church in America. Its people kept Christmas by the old Julian calendar, on January 7, and began it the evening before with the meatless Holy Supper, straw under the tablecloth and a cross of honey on each forehead. Captain

Halpern's Bible is the Jewish Publication Society translation, which first appeared in 1917.

After the story of the Elder Sāriputta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 95). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society translation (1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7·7

One Hand

As runs the Glass,
Our Life doth pass.
— The New-England Primer Improved (1777)

This is the way it was handed down, on the north side of the Island.

I. The Shears

South of Huntington, Long Island · March 1779

NATHAN CONKLIN WAS A MINISTER'S SON FROM THE EAST END who had left college in the second year of the war, and in the third winter of the King's troops on Long Island he kept a school of eleven children in the back kitchen of Deacon Jesse Ketcham's farm, and boarded there. That was all the garrison at Huntington knew of him. He also carried letters. There were lines across the Island in those years, like the one Major Tallmadge's friends kept at Setauket, by which what was seen in New York on a Monday could be in Connecticut by the week's end, and the deacon's kitchen was a station on one of them.

When the school broke up for planting, the deacon set the winter's pay on the table: four yards of tow cloth, a crock of butter, a cheese, and two shillings in hard money.

I thank you, and I cannot take it, said Conklin.

It is what the schoolmaster has always had in this house.

I have forty miles to walk and nobody to carry so much as my shoes. A man alone on the road with a pack is stopped at every post. I have no boy.

The deacon thought about it for the space of a breath. *Then you shall have mine,* he said, and called his son Eli in from the yard. Eli was seven years old.

Conklin said a boy on the road wanted a short head, for the lice in the barns. He sat the child on a stool by the door, wet his hair from the basin, and took the sheep shears to it. To keep him still he gave him the primer open at the pictures and had him say the rhymes over.

As runs the Glass,
Our Life doth pass.

Xerxes did die,
And so must I.

While youth do chear
Death may be near.

— The New-England Primer Improved (1777)

Every child in the school had said those lines a hundred times and gone out to slide on the pond. The Ketchams held ever after that Eli, with his hair falling on the floor, heard them. They said that between one closing of the shears and the next he took the whole of what the little book has to tell, and was finished with it, and that when he got down from the stool he was quiet in a way he had not been when he got up on it. His mother saw it and did not know what to call it. Conklin, who was twenty-two and had a great deal on his mind, saw a well-behaved child.

The letters were sewn that night into the boards of the primer, under the blue paper. Nobody searches a child's primer. For two weeks more Conklin stayed at the farm, and then the two of them set out east.

II. The Third Night

Smithtown Branch · April 1779

The first night they slept in a barn in the Dix Hills, and the second in a weaver's loft at Comac. On the third evening they came to a tavern at the Branch, and a foraging party of dragoons was in it. There were eleven troopers and a sergeant, their horses filling the stable and the shed and their saddles heaped in the public room.

The woman of the house had one garret left, with one bed. She would let the schoolmaster have it if his boy would do the morning work, since her own girl had run off when the horses came. Eli carried up the master's pack and the primer. He beat the bed and turned it, found a candle end, brought water, and went down to learn where the broom was kept and where the back-house stood. By the time he had done all that it was full dark, and he had found no corner for himself. The stable was horses to the door. The public room was troopers.

When he came up to see whether anything more was wanted, Conklin asked, *Where do you lie tonight?*

I have not had time to look, sir.

Then stay here. I'll not have you on the stairs among them.

Now the line had a rule, and Conklin had given his word to it. He knew it as he knew his own name. *Where the letters are, one wakes.* Two of the line might share a roof if they must, but they did not both sleep. He meant to take the watch himself. He lay down in his clothes to rest his back for a quarter of an hour, and he was asleep before the candle end was out, for he was a tired young man who had not yet learned how to carry what he carried.

Eli stood by the bed and considered it. If he lay down on the floor and slept, then both had slept, and the master had broken his word, though he would never know. So the boy sat down on the boards between the bed and the door with his legs crossed and his back straight and the primer in his lap, and sat there awake until morning. Below him the dragoons sang for a while and then left off.

Conklin woke in the grey before sunrise with the rule in his mouth. He had slept the night through. The boy must be up and out and at the yard work before the troopers were stirring, and seen to be nothing but a tavern's chore boy. He supposed the child was curled asleep on the floor at the bed's foot. He reached down for his walking stick, a hazel with a knob to it, and rapped the boards with the tip where he took the boy's feet to be, and then tossed the stick away from him toward the corner by the door.

Up, Eli. Go out.

The boy was not at the bed's foot. He was sitting upright by the door, and the knob of the stick took him in the left eye and put it out.

He made no sound at all. After a moment he said, *What was it you said, sir?*

I said get up and go out.

Eli got up. He put his left hand over the eye and went out and down the stairs.

III. The Basin

The same morning

He did not sit down in the yard, and he did not go and say to anyone that his eye was put out. There was the morning work, which he had promised. He kept his left palm pressed where it was and did the work with his right. He carried down the pot. He swept out the back-house and the wash bench with the birch broom. He drew a bucket at the well, one-handed, a pull and a turn round the post and another pull.

The sergeant of dragoons came out to the trough in his shirt and watched this.

What have you there under your arm, boy?

My letters, sir, said Eli, and held the primer out to him.

The sergeant did not take it. *Can you read them?*

Eli opened the book against his chest with his one hand and read out, *Whales in the Sea, GOD's Voice obey,* in the voice he would have used in the deacon's kitchen. The sergeant laughed, and asked what he had done to his face, and Eli said a stick had caught it, which was true. The sergeant said he should mind where he ran, and put his own head in the trough.

Then Eli swept the garret stairs and the garret, around the master's feet, and filled the basin from the bucket and brought it for the master to wash. He brought it in his right hand, held against his hip, and some of it slopped on the boards.

Conklin had been sitting on the bed's edge angry with himself for sleeping, and it came out sideways. *Is that how a basin is brought, in the deacon's house? In one hand, like a pot-boy? You were taught better.*

I know how it should be brought, sir. One of my hands is not free.

What is the matter with it?

So the boy told him, from the beginning: the rule, and the sitting up, and where he had been sitting, and the stick. He took his palm away for as long as it needed and then put it back.

Conklin looked. Then that young man of family, who had read Greek at New Haven and had the lives of a dozen people sewn in a primer, got down on the garret floor on both knees before a child of seven, and put up his two hands together.

Eli. Forgive me. I did not know. Be my help in this, for I have none.

I did not tell you for that, sir, said Eli. *I told you because you asked about the basin. I kept it back so you should not be grieved. It is no fault of yours, and it is none of mine. It is only the glass running. We are in the world, and things fall out so in it, and there is no one to lay it on.*

He tried a while longer to comfort the man, as well as he could with the dragoons saddling under the window. Conklin would not be comforted. When they left the tavern he took the boy's bundle on his own back with his pack, and the primer inside his shirt, and they went on along the North Country Road, and where the sand was deep he carried the boy too.

IV. Old Mans

The harbor called Old Mans · evening

THE WOMAN THEY WERE GOING TO LIVED BEHIND THE BEACH at Old Mans, in a round house of poles and mats beside a patch of beans. She was one of the Montauk people. As a girl she had gone to school at Montauk to Mr. Occom, the Mohegan minister, in the years he taught there, and had her reading from him. Her name in the towns was Dorcas. She made scrub brushes of white oak splint, and splint baskets, and brooms, and walked the north side of the Island selling them at kitchen

DOORS, AND NO SENTRY HAD EVER ASKED AN OLD INDIAN WOman what was in a broom. Whaleboat men from the Connecticut shore bought of her too, when they came over in the dark. Her own grandson was in a whaler out of Sag Harbor, the war permitting. She meant to go up to the Oneida country with Mr. Occom's people when the roads were open, and plant there.

She saw them from a long way down the beach, the man bent under two bundles and a child. When they came up she looked first at the boy's face and moved his hand and looked under it, and put the hand back. She did not say the eye would mend. Then she asked the schoolmaster, as anyone asks a traveler, whether he was well and had come without much hardship.

I am well. I have had no hardship, said Conklin. *But this boy. I have never seen the like of him.*

What has he done?

He told her all of it, not sparing himself the sleep or the stick or the words about the basin. *And when I begged his pardon on my knees he said it was no fault of mine nor of his, only the glass running, and I was not to grieve. He set himself to comfort me. There is no anger in him. I looked for it. I have never in my life seen such a child.*

Dorcas went on splitting a splint with her thumbnail until it was split.

One who has let the burning go out of him holds no anger against anybody, she said. *You were looking in an empty house. He is quiet in what he thinks. He is quiet in what he says and quiet in what he does. He knows how things are, and so he is loose from them. A person like that is at rest.*

She had the primer from him then, and slit the blue paper with the same thumbnail. It is told that Nathan Conklin, sitting on the sand with her words in his ears and the boy asleep at last against the wall of the house, came to rest himself that evening, and that he carried letters for four years more and was never once afraid, nor once careless.

• • •

Eli Ketcham kept school at Huntington South for fifty-one years, a one-eyed man who taught the grandchildren of his first scholars out of the

same primer with its boards twice mended. He had a way of waiting for a child to finish that people remembered. There was a broom behind his door, and in fifty-one years there was never a stick in the room.

Background

The verse

> *His thought is quiet, quiet are his word and deed, when he has obtained freedom by true knowledge, when he has thus become a quiet man.*
>
> Dhammapada 96, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Tissa of Kosambī declines his patron's gifts because he has no novice to attend him, and the patron gives him his seven-year-old son. The boy becomes an arahat the instant the razor touches his hair, while the elder gives him the first meditation on the body. On the road, the two share a lodging for a third night, which the rule forbids if the novice lies down; so the novice sits up until morning. At dawn the elder, meaning to send him out, tosses a fan whose handle puts out the boy's eye. The boy says nothing, covers the eye, does his duties with one hand, and is scolded for offering the toothstick one-handed. When the elder learns the truth and begs pardon, the novice says that neither of them is to blame, only the round of existence. The elder tells the Buddha, who speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.

Smithtown Branch, Long Island, New York

Long Island, 1779

British and Loyalist troops held Long Island from August 1776 until 1783, with garrisons at Huntington, Oyster Bay, Setauket and elsewhere, and foraging parties took hay, cattle and lodging from the farms. Intelligence about the army in New York

crossed the Island and then Long Island Sound to Connecticut by several routes. The best known is the Culper Ring, organized in 1778 by Major Benjamin Tallmadge around Setauket, whose couriers rode the fifty-odd miles from the city and whose whaleboats crossed the Sound at night. Conklin, the Ketchams, the tavern and their line are invented, as is the line's rule. The rhymed alphabet is quoted from the 1777 Boston edition of The New-England Primer, the small schoolbook from which most children in the northern colonies learned to read for more than a century; Old Mans is the old name of the harbor at Mount Sinai.

The Montaukett are the people of the east end of Long Island. By the 1770s, crowded onto a fraction of their land at Montauk, many worked as whalers, farm laborers and servants across the Island, and Montaukett and Shinnecock women were known for the baskets, brooms and oak-splint scrub brushes they made and sold from door to door. Samson Occom, a Mohegan and an ordained Presbyterian minister, lived at Montauk from 1749 to 1761 as schoolmaster and preacher and married Mary Fowler, a Montaukett woman. In the 1770s he and his brother-in-law David Fowler led the plan to move Christian families of several coastal nations to Oneida land in upper New York; the war interrupted it, and the settlement, Brothertown, was founded in 1785. Dorcas is invented, and her words are her own.

After the story of Kosambivāsī Tissa′s novice from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 96). The original. Rhymes from The New-England Primer Improved (Boston, 1777). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

7.8

The Demon Star

> *We must at least question it; we cannot accept anything as granted, beyond the first mathematical formulae. Question everything else.*
> *— Maria Mitchell, Life, Letters, and Journals*

The way they tell it, up to Harlow.

I. The Examination

Harlow Academy, Caledonia County, Vermont · December 1899

Three weeks before the fall examination, on the word of the astronomers, the whole village of Harlow sat up to see the stars fall. The Boston papers had promised it since summer. The November meteors were due again, as in 'thirty-three and 'sixty-six, when they had come down like snow. Deacon Stiles kept his hired men up at his own expense. Mr. Peck had his text chosen. They watched three nights and counted a few dozen in the best hour, and the stars stayed where they were, and afterward the village held a low opinion of astronomy that it was at no trouble to keep from Miss Wing.

Miss Lois Wing taught natural science and the higher mathematics at Harlow Academy. She was forty-four. She had studied at Vassar College under Miss Maria Mitchell, and afterward she had worked six years at the Harvard observatory, measuring stars on glass plates at twenty-five cents an hour, in a room of women who were the best eyes in the country, until her mother's last illness called her home. She had brought back a three-inch glass on a tripod, a habit of saying less than she knew, and a contempt for the marking system, which the trustees had got round by having her assistant keep the mark book.

The assistant was Ruth Hadlock. She was nineteen, she worked for her board at Miss Wing's, and she heard the lower classes in algebra. She came from Victory, over in Essex County, at the far end of the logging road. Her father, Asa Hadlock, was the infidel of that town. He took Colonel Ingersoll's lectures in paper covers, and since July, when the Colonel died, he had worn a band of crape on his sleeve, the only mourning anyone had known him to put on. It was understood in Harlow that the girl had never got clear of him.

Thirty new scholars had entered that fall. Most were from the woods towns, from Victory and Granby and the camps up the Moose River: boys who would go back to the choppings after New Year's, girls who meant to keep school. They boarded themselves, four to a room, on what came down from home in a box. They were quick and biddable, and by December they could recite Professor Young's Lessons in Astronomy from the Great Bear to the nebular hypothesis without a fault.

The examination was held in the upper hall on the fifth of December, before the trustees and anyone else who cared to climb the stairs. The stove was red. Mr. Peck, the Congregational minister, sat in the middle, with Deacon Stiles on one side of him and Dr. Brock on the other. The thirty stood in a row. Miss Wing asked and they answered, and it went like a mill.

Algol, said a boy from Granby. *Beta Persei. The name is Arabic and signifies the Demon. A variable star. Period, two days, twenty hours and forty-nine minutes. For the most of that time it is of the second magnitude. Then in some four hours and a half it loses the greater part of its light, and in as many more regains it.*

Explained how?

By the passage of a dark companion before the bright star. First proposed by John Goodricke, of York, in 1783.

That is the book, said Miss Wing, and the committee nodded, since it was.

She looked along the row a moment. Then she turned to the side table, where Ruth Hadlock sat with the mark book.

Miss Hadlock. These scholars have told the committee that the star Algol goes dim every two days, twenty hours and forty-nine minutes. They have it from Professor Young, and from me. Do you believe it?

No, ma'am, said Ruth Hadlock.

The stove ticked.

Not on Professor Young's word, and not on yours. I have watched it go down and come back. Nineteen times off the belfry deck, and once off my father's woodshed. I don't believe it. I know it. She looked at the thirty, not unkindly. *Those who have not sat up for it will have to take your word. I don't see what else they can do.*

That will do, said Miss Wing. *Thank you.*

II. The Committee

The upper hall · the same afternoon

THE SCHOLARS WERE SENT DOWN. THE COMMITTEE STAYED.

Mr. Peck spoke first, and he was not an unkind man. He said the whole county had been made fools of in November by taking the word of astronomers, and he could have understood a little modesty from that quarter in December. Instead a girl of nineteen had been stood up before the entering class to say she did not believe her teacher. *It is the father,* he said. *She has not given up one of his notions. She would not believe Moses, and now she will not believe you.*

Deacon Stiles set it out under five heads, the way he did at town meeting. The girl believed nothing she was told. She was ungrateful to the woman whose bread she ate. She was a housebreaker besides, for Dow the janitor had twice found the staple drawn on the belfry scuttle. She had thrown away her chances, since Granby wanted a teacher for the spring term and the men who would be asked about her were sitting in this room. And the worst of it, he said, was that she did not appear to want anything of anybody.

Miss Wing heard him through.

Gentlemen, why do you say so? I did not ask her whether she believed in her Maker. I did not ask whether she was thankful for her board. I asked whether

she took a star on my say-so, and she does not, because she has gone up in the cold and looked. In October I asked her another thing, which you did not hear. I asked whether anybody could come to know that star without sitting up for it. She said nobody could. That is the whole creed I have examined her in.

You say it is the father. Asa Hadlock takes Colonel Ingersoll's word for a great many things. She does not take that either.

As to the rest, Deacon, you have every head right. She does not believe what she is told. She owes me nothing; she has earned her board twice over. She did draw the staple. I lent her the file. She has spoiled her chances with you, and she wants nothing from you, which I suppose is how she came to answer as she did. You have described the best observer I ever met with, and I worked six years in a room with the best in America.

There was a book on her desk. She did not open it to find the place.

Miss Mitchell wrote this of women. I do not find it truer of them than of deacons.

> *What the father, the brother, the doctor, and the minister have said has been received undoubtingly. Until women throw off this reverence for authority they will not develop. When they do this, when they come to truth through their investigations, when doubt leads them to discovery, the truth which they get will be theirs, and their minds will work on and on unfettered.*
>
> *— Maria Mitchell, Life, Letters, and Journals*

Dr. Brock laughed once and turned it into a cough. Mr. Peck looked at the stove.

III. The Belfry Deck

The night of the sixth

By Miss Wing's reckoning the star would be at its least a little before midnight on the sixth. She wrote the hour on the board in the lower hall, and under it one more line of Miss Mitchell's, and nothing else.

> *We must at least question it; we cannot accept anything as granted, beyond the first mathematical formulae. Question everything else.*
>
> *— Maria Mitchell, Life, Letters, and Journals*

She did not go up herself. She had seen it.

It was eight above zero and dead clear, and the young moon was down early. They came up the belfry ladder one at a time through the scuttle, which nobody had mended, all thirty, in mufflers and their fathers' coats, and stood on the deck packed like sheep. Ruth Hadlock came last. She carried the lantern up the ladder in both hands, the way a full pail is carried, with a piece of red flannel tied over the glass.

She gave each of them a card with six stars pricked on it and no names. She showed them where Algol stood, at one corner of a three-cornered figure with Alpha of Perseus and Almach in Andromeda. She showed them Epsilon and Delta farther up in Perseus, and Rho, the little star close beside Algol. Then she told them the only thing she told them that night.

Don't ask me what it is doing. Don't ask each other. Every quarter hour, look, and put down which of these it is brighter than and which it is fainter than. I will call the quarters from Miss Wing's watch. If you see nothing, put that down.

At half past seven it was the equal of Almach, and a boy from Granby said so aloud and was told to write and not talk. At a quarter to eleven a girl from Victory said in a small voice, to nobody, that it had gone under Epsilon. A little before midnight it was no better than Rho, a common star among common stars, and the figure she had shown them had a hole in its corner.

Nobody spoke. There were thirty pencils going, and the cold came up through the boards. Down on the common Dr. Brock, driving home late from a confinement on the Kirby road, stopped his horse in the middle of the street and sat with his head back for the better part of an hour. There was a lamp in the parsonage study, and then there was not, and the front door opened and stayed open.

At one it had begun to mend. By two it stood over Epsilon again, and she sent them down the ladder, stiff as boards. They did not talk on the stairs.

• • •

Ruth Hadlock did not get the Granby school. That winter she sent her estimates to Cambridge over her own name, and in the spring a letter came back from the observatory asking for more.

The thirty cards stayed in Miss Wing's drawer. No two of them agreed to the quarter hour, and none was copied from another. She had read every one at the window the morning after, and she never marked them.

Background

The verse

> *The man who is free from credulity, but knows the uncreated, who has cut all ties, removed all temptations, renounced all desires, he is the greatest of men.*
>
> Dhammapada 97, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, thirty forest-dwelling monks come to the Buddha, and he sees that they are ready. For their sake he turns to his chief disciple and asks: Sāriputta, do you believe that faith, developed and made much of, ends in the deathless? Sāriputta answers that in this matter he does not go by faith in the Blessed One, because he has seen it for himself; those who have not seen it must go by the faith of others. The other monks mutter that he has never given up his old wrong views and will not believe even the Buddha. The Buddha defends him and speaks a verse made of five words that can each be heard as an insult, *faithless, ungrateful, a housebreaker, one who has ruined his chances, an eater of what is thrown up,* and each of which also means its opposite: beyond mere belief, knowing the unmade, having broken the chain, having ended the occasion for rebirth, having spat out desire. The thirty reach full awakening. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.

Caledonia County, Vermont

Vermont, 1899

Maria Mitchell (1818–1889), who found a comet from a Nantucket rooftop in 1847, was professor of astronomy at Vassar College from its opening in 1865. She put her students at the telescope, refused to grade them ("You cannot mark a human mind," her successor remembered her saying), and told the class of 1876, "We are women studying together." Her sister published Maria Mitchell: Life, Letters, and Journals in 1896; both passages quoted here are from her notes of the 1870s in that book. At the Harvard College Observatory, from the 1880s, Edward Pickering hired women known as the Harvard computers to measure and classify stars on photographic plates, at wages commonly given as twenty-five to fifty cents an hour. Miss Wing, Ruth Hadlock, the committee and Harlow Academy are invented. Victory and Granby are real towns in Essex County, and Robert Ingersoll, "the Great Agnostic," died on July 21, 1899.

Algol, Beta Persei, takes its name from the Arabic *ra's al-ghūl*, the ogre's head. Every 2 days, 20 hours and 49 minutes it fades from about magnitude 2.1 to 3.4 and recovers, over some ten hours, and the whole of it can be followed without a telescope by comparing it with its neighbors. John Goodricke, a deaf eighteen-year-old in York, worked out the period in 1782–83 and proposed that a dark body was passing in front of the star; the spectroscope confirmed it in 1889. In November 1899 the Leonid meteors, which had stormed in 1833 and 1866, were widely predicted to do so again. They did not, and the astronomer Charles Olivier later called the failure "the worst blow ever suffered by astronomy in the eyes of the public."

After the story of the question put to the elder Sāriputta, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 97). The original. Scripture from Maria Mitchell: Life, Letters, and Journals (1896). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

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Uña de Gato

> *The land that was desolate and impassable shall be glad, and the wilderness shall rejoice, and shall flourish like the lily.*
> *— Isaias 35:1*

Así lo oí contar, at the ford of El Paso del Norte.

I. The Grandmother

San José del Parral, Nueva Vizcaya · spring 1672

Doña Leonor de Arteaga was the widow of a silver miner, and she had seven children, and the Church had taken six. Her eldest, Diego, who should have had the mines, gave his share to the poor in the plaza of Parral on a single morning and walked north to New Mexico in the gray habit of Saint Francis, and in New Mexico they called him Fray Diego de San Antonio and had forgotten he had ever had another name. Her three daughters were in the convent of Jesús María in Mexico City behind a grille. Her second son was a Jesuit in Durango, and her third was a Franciscan somewhere in Sonora that she could not find on a map.

That left Rodrigo, who was seven.

If this one goes, she told her confessor, *the mines go to the Crown and my husband's name goes into the ground with him. I will tie him to the house while he is still small enough to tie.*

The Church allowed a betrothal from the age of seven. Doña Leonor found a girl of nine from a family with a hacienda of sheep on the Florido, and arranged the promise, and on the day of the espousals she dressed her son in black velvet with a lace collar and a little sword and a

gold chain across his chest, and put him in the coach with six mules, and took him with half of Parral behind them to the house of the bride.

The kin of both houses stood in the sala. They dipped their fingers in a silver basin of water and blessed the children. Then the bride's aunts turned her by the shoulders toward a chair by the window and said to her, laughing, *Look, there is your great-grandmother. May you live as long as she has.*

Rodrigo looked where they were looking. *Which one is her great-grandmother?*

Why, there, young sir, in the chair. Doña Mencía.

She was said to be a hundred and four. She had come up from Zacatecas in an oxcart when there was nothing at Santa Bárbara but the first mines. She had two teeth. Her hair was thin and white as raw cotton, and her face was all folds, and her hands lay in her lap spotted like a quail's egg, and her back was bent like a beam under a load of roof.

Will Juana look like that?

The aunts laughed again. *If God gives her the years.*

Rodrigo looked at the girl in her stiff yellow silk, who was picking at the sugar on a little cake, and then at the old woman, and then at the girl again. *So that is what Diego saw,* he thought. *That is why he went.* And he decided, standing there in his velvet with the gold chain on his chest, that he would go that same day.

II. The Wagon Camp

The road outside Parral · the same day

On the way home in the coach he said he needed to make water. The coachman stopped the mules, and he got down and went behind a mesquite and came back. A little farther on he said it again, and got down, and came back. The third time his mother's cousin sighed and said that the boy had eaten too much at the espousals, and nobody watched him anymore. The fourth time he said, *Go on ahead, I'll walk behind,* and they went on ahead.

Outside Parral, where the road came down from the hills, a train of wagons was camped for the night on its way north to New Mexico, with friars going up to the missions and a few soldiers for escort, and the mules and oxen grazing around them on what grass there was. Rodrigo walked into the firelight in his velvet and his lace and his gold chain, and knelt to the first friar he saw, and asked to be given the habit.

There were thirty of them in that camp, more or less. They looked at him.

Child, you are dressed like a viceroy's son. We don't know whose son you are. How can we give you the habit?

Don't you know me? I'm Diego de Arteaga's brother.

Who is Diego de Arteaga?

Rodrigo thought. *You call him Fray Diego de San Antonio.*

The friars looked at each other, and then all of them began to talk at once. Fray Diego, before he went north the last time, had said it to every friar of the Custody he met. *If my little brother ever comes to you asking for the habit, give it to him that same hour. Don't send to my mother to ask. She will say no. I am his father and his mother now.*

So they took off the gold chain and the little sword and the lace, and sent them back to Parral by a muleteer with a letter, and the friar who mended their sandals cut down a gray habit to the boy's size by the fire, and they tied the cord around him three times because there was so little of him. A letter went north to Santa Fe the next morning with a soldier riding ahead of the train.

When it came, Fray Diego took it to the old friar, Fray Gil de la Concepción, who had been born in New Mexico, at San Gabriel, in the first years of the colony, and had never once seen Spain. Fray Diego asked leave to ride south and meet the train.

Stay here for now, Fray Gil said.

A week later Fray Diego asked again.

Stay here for now, Diego. We will go together, later.

Meanwhile the train went north, slowly, and the boy walked beside the wagons in his cut-down habit. At El Paso del Norte, where the road forded the river, he heard that two of his mother's men had come up be-

hind the train asking for him. So he went to the oldest friar in the train and asked him for something to pray that would take him all the way, to the end, and the old man gave it to him, a few words to say and a way to sit. When the train went on north the boy stayed behind at the bottom of the Jornada del Muerto, where the river turned away into the mountains and the road went straight out across the dry plain, and walked off the road a league toward the river into the uña de gato, the catclaw, where nobody lived and nobody would come after him, and sat down.

III. The Catclaw

The bench above the river, south end of the Jornada · summer 1672

THE CATCLAW GREW ON A GRAVEL BENCH ABOVE THE RIVER IN a thicket a man could not walk through standing. Every branch was set with small hooked thorns that took your sleeve and would not let it go, so that you had to stop, and back up, and unhook yourself one thorn at a time. Wait a minute, the thorns said to anyone who came in. The soldiers had worse names for it.

It was a drought year, in a run of them. Up the river the pueblos had little in their granaries, and a friar had written to Mexico that Spaniards and Indians alike were eating hides and the straps of the carts. The Apaches came down on the horse herds when they were hungry, which was always. The boy lived in the catclaw on what the bench gave him, mesquite beans and the water of the river, and said his few words, and sat.

In July the rains came up out of the south in the afternoons, black clouds with the lightning walking under them, and the catclaw put out its flowers, little pale yellow spikes like cattails that smelled of honey from a hundred yards off. Before the rains were over, before the cottonwoods along the river had begun to turn, the boy had come to the end of what the old friar gave him. He did not tell anybody. There was nobody to tell.

IV. The Dead Man's Road

Fray Cristóbal, north end of the Jornada · October 1672

In October, when the rains were done, Fray Diego asked a third time, and Fray Gil said, *Now we will go.* They went down the river from Santa Fe with a good many friars and lay brothers, and soldiers, and settlers going south, and herds, and the wagons that were going back down to Mexico empty, more than five hundred souls all told by the time they gathered at Fray Cristóbal, where the road leaves the river.

Fray Lucas, who was young and kept the old friar's papers and walked at his elbow, stood with him where the road forked.

Father, there are two ways to where the boy is. One is the river way, around through the mountains. It is long, but there is water every day, and there are people. The other is the Jornada, straight across. It is ninety miles and half as long, and there is no water on it, and the Apaches watch it, and since they found the German's bones out there two years ago the soldiers say it is not a place for Christians at night. Which shall we take?

Is Fray Silvestre with us?

Yes, Father.

If Silvestre is with us, take the Jornada.

Fray Silvestre was a lay brother from Zacatecas, a big soft-voiced man who looked after the mules, and he had never in his life gone without anything. It was a thing everyone in the Custody knew. If a ranchero killed a sheep, a leg of it found its way to Silvestre. If a governor's wife had chocolate sent up from Mexico, a cake of it ended in Silvestre's sleeve. In the hungry years Indians in the pueblos who had nothing gave him something anyway, a handful of piñons, a twist of chile, and went away looking pleased. He gave all of it away again as fast as it came. He could not help any of it, and he was a little embarrassed by it, as a man is by a wart.

They took the Jornada. What happened on it is told in the Custody to this day, and the soldiers who were there told it the same way as the friars, which was unusual.

At every league along the dead man's road, where there was no water and never had been, they found a ramada of fresh brush standing by the trail, with its shade swept, and under it big clay jars of water, sweating and cold, and baskets of tortillas still warm in their cloths, and dried meat and piñons and squash, and nobody there. No tracks went to them or away. The soldiers looked for tracks. In the mornings, before light, the friars at the head of the column heard voices ahead of them in the dark asking, in a Spanish that was a little strange, the way a song is strange, *Where is Brother Silvestre? Which one is Brother Silvestre?* And Silvestre, red to the ears, would go out ahead with his lantern and come back with his arms full, and bring all of it to Fray Gil, and Fray Gil had it shared out among the column, friars and soldiers and settlers and the Manso boys who drove the herds, and there was more than enough. They went the ninety miles of the Jornada in short stages, a league a day and no more, and nobody was thirsty once. They said afterward that the whole Custody had crossed the dead man's road on the luck of one lay brother.

Down at the bottom of it, in the catclaw, the boy knew they were coming.

V. The Convento

The bench above the river · October and November 1672

When they came off the Jornada at the south end and turned toward the river, the catclaw bench was a convento.

That is how it is told. There was a church of white stone with a bell in its wall, and a cloister around a garden with a fountain running in it, and a cell for Fray Gil with a bed and a writing table and a window toward the river that smelled of something like incense, and five hundred cells for the rest of them, every one with its door and its cot, and long covered walks for the hot hours and the night, and a refectory with a table that ran the length of it. The boy stood at the gate in his cut-down habit with the cord wrapped around him three times, and knelt to Fray Gil, and then to his brother. Fray Diego picked him up off the ground and held him and could not say anything at all.

They stayed a month. Every morning there were voices on the road asking for Brother Silvestre, and every morning Silvestre came back with his arms full.

There were two old friars in the company, Fray Hernando and Fray Blas, who had been forty years at missions where the church was mud and the friars ate what the pueblo ate, and they did not like what they saw. They said it to each other in the covered walk, in low voices.

When does a child pray, with all this building to see to?

And the old man comes ninety miles through the Jornada to stay a month in it. Because the child is Diego de Arteaga's brother. Because the family has silver. That is all this is.

Fray Gil, walking in the garden early on the first morning, saw them talking and knew what they were saying. On the day the company left, when he had gone out of the gate a little way, he stopped on the road and stood there with his eyes closed for about as long as it takes to say a Credo.

Fray Hernando put his hand to his belt. *My breviary. I left it on the cot.* Fray Blas looked at his feet and found he had come out in his old worn sandals and left the good ones under the bed, and his water gourd too. The two of them turned back.

There was no convento. There was the gravel bench above the river and the catclaw on it, gray and hooked, so thick a man could not walk through it standing. They went in after their things anyway, because the breviary had been Fray Hernando's since his ordination, and the catclaw took their sleeves and their hoods and the skin of their hands, and the thorns went into their feet through the old sandals, and they went in and out among the bushes all morning and could not find any place that looked like a place where anything had been. At last they found the breviary and the good sandals and the gourd hanging together on a branch of catclaw at the height of a man's head, hooked there neatly by their straps, as if somebody had hung them up for them to see. They unhooked them one thorn at a time and walked back up to the road bleeding, and caught up with the company by evening.

Fray Gil stayed on the river another month after that, at the friars' camp by the ford, and then went home up the river to Santa Fe.

VI. The Widow's Table

Santa Fe · winter 1673

Doña Beatriz de Anaya was the richest widow in New Mexico, as riches went there, and she gave to the friars more than anyone. Her husband's tribute came in from three pueblos in corn and blankets, in good years and in bad, and she knew where it came from, and she gave as if she knew. Any friar passing through Santa Fe who came to her door was fed in her kitchen, and there was chocolate for him if there was chocolate in the town.

Fray Hernando and Fray Blas came the first morning after they got back, with their feet still bound in rags, and sat in her kitchen and drank atole.

Fathers, you went with Fray Gil to see Fray Diego's little brother?

We did, señora.

They tell me it is a beautiful place where the child lives.

Fray Hernando put his cup down. *Beautiful? Señora, it is a thicket of uña de gato on a gravel bank. You cannot walk in it. It is fit for hermits and javelinas, and not many javelinas.* And he showed her his hands.

That same morning, a little later, two young friars came to her door who had also been with the company. One of them was Fray Lucas. She sat them down and gave them atole and asked them the same.

Señora, I can't tell you what it was like, Fray Lucas said. *There are no words for it in Spanish. It was like the cloister of San Francisco in Mexico, only finer. It was like what the Apocalypse says about the city. I slept a month in a cell there and never wanted for anything.*

Doña Beatriz sat a while with her hands in her lap after they had gone. The old ones said one thing and the young ones said another, and she did not think any of the four of them was lying. She thought she could see how it might be. She did not say it. She said, *I will ask Fray Gil,* and waited.

He came to her table on the feast of the Epiphany with Fray Diego and a dozen others. When she had served them and they had eaten, she knelt by his chair and asked him plainly. *Father, some of the ones who went with you say the boy lives in a thorn thicket, and some say he lives in a palace. Which is it?*

Fray Gil was very old by then, and he did not talk much, and when he did talk it was often in Latin, which he had learned before he learned to read Spanish, from the friars at Santo Domingo. He said a line of it to her.

Laetabitur deserta et invia et exultabit solitudo et florebit quasi lilium.

Then, because she was waiting, he said it again in her own language, and said he did not mean only the boy's bench. He meant a pueblo or a plaza or the open desert, the bottom of a river or the top of a mesa. Wherever people like that boy lived, he said, the ground was glad of it.

> *The land that was desolate and impassable shall be glad, and the wilderness shall rejoice, and shall flourish like the lily.*
>
> *— Isaias 35:1*

Doña Beatriz nodded as though he had told her where a thing she had lost was. Fray Hernando, who was at the table too, with his feet in clean bandages, looked at his hands for a long time.

VII. The Honey

The convento at Santa Fe · Lent 1673

That winter, at the convento in Santa Fe, the friars talked at recreation about Fray Silvestre. Why was it that a lay brother who could barely read was never once in want, when governors went hungry? And why, Silvestre's own mother had told everyone in Zacatecas, had she labored seven days to bear him, with the child lying crosswise in her, so that the women gave her up twice?

Fray Gil, who heard most things, asked what they were talking about, and they told him. He said there was a tale the old people told in the Rio Abajo, which they had from the first friars, who had it from Spain, the

way such tales go. He told it to them the way the friars told exempla in a sermon, and they listened the way friars listen to a sermon at recreation, half smiling.

Once, he said, a king and the council of his town fell to rivalry over which of them could give the greater feast to a holy man who had come to them with his followers. The king gave a feast, and the town gave a greater one, and the king a greater, back and forth, six times. The seventh time the town swore there would be nothing lacking from its table, and they looked it over, and saw there was cooked honey but no fresh honey in the comb. So they sent men out of all four gates with a thousand coins each to find some.

On the road a countryman was walking into town with a branch over his shoulder with a comb of wild honey on it, which he had cut from a tree by the road, to give to his village alcalde. One of the town's men stopped him and asked if the honey was for sale. No, said the countryman. Take a coin for it anyway, the man said. The countryman thought: this comb is not worth a copper, and he is offering a coin for it, so he must have a good many coins. He said, not for one. Two, then, said the man. Not for two. And so up, and up, until the man offered him the whole thousand, and he took it, and then stood in the road with the purse in one hand and the honey in the other and said: Are you mad? This is not worth a copper. What do you want it for?

The man told him. It was for the holy man's table, and there was no fresh honey in all that feast. The countryman put the purse back in his hands. If it is for that, he said, I won't sell it for any price. Let me give it, and have the good of the giving. The town agreed. They strained the comb into a great silver basin, and the countryman went home and came back with a pot of clabbered milk of his own and stirred it in, and they set it before the holy man and his followers, and there were many hundreds of them, and every one ate as much as he wanted, and there was some left.

A friar asked how one comb fed so many.

Don't ask that, said Fray Gil. *There are four things a man can go mad thinking about, and how God feeds people is one of them.*

That same countryman, he went on, a long time later, was made a captain, and was sent to take a town. He sat down in front of its four great gates for seven years and seven months, and the town did not fall, because the people went in and out by the little gates in the walls for wood and water. His mother heard of it and sent to him. My son is a fool, she said. Tell him to shut the little gates. He did, and the town could not get out for wood or water, and on the seventh day it gave itself up. And for the honey, said Fray Gil, he was never in want, in this world or the next. And for the little gates, he was a long time getting out of where he went, and a long time coming in, wherever he came in.

Was that Brother Silvestre, Father? one of the young friars asked, grinning.

Fray Gil smiled a little and did not answer, and somebody laughed, and the bell rang for Compline.

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Another evening that Lent they talked about the boy. Think of the merit, they said, a child who could raise a convento with five hundred cells out of a thorn bush for the old man to sleep in. Think what he must have laid up in heaven by now, at eight years old.

Fray Gil came in from the cold with his hands in his sleeves and heard it.

That child is not keeping any account, he said. *Not of the good and not of the other. He let both go, down there in the uña de gato. If you asked him, he would tell you what the servants say in Saint Luke.*

> *So you also, when you shall have done all these things that are commanded you, say: We are unprofitable servants; we have done that which we ought to do.*
>
> *— Luke 17:10*

Down on the bench above the river, in March, before anything else on the desert had leaves, the catclaw put out new shoots, red-brown and soft, with the thorns on them still green and bending, not yet hooked. A

little gray habit hung on one branch to dry, with its cord coiled under it on the gravel, three turns.

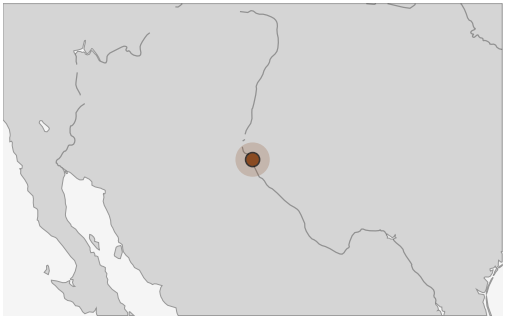
Background

The verses

> *In a hamlet or in a forest, in the deep water or on the dry land, wherever venerable persons (Arhanta) dwell, that place is delightful.*
>
> Dhammapada 98, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who in this world is above good and evil, above the bondage of both, free from grief from sin, and from impurity.*
>
> Dhammapada 412, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Sāriputta and five of his brothers and sisters have all become monastics, and their mother marries the youngest, Revata, at seven to keep him at home. At the wedding the kin bless the bride to live as long as her grandmother, a woman of a hundred and twenty, toothless and bent; Revata sees what his brother saw, slips away from the carriage on the pretext of relieving himself, and asks some forest monks for ordination. They do not know who "Upatissa" is until he gives his brother's monastic name, and they ordain him on his brother's standing instruction. He goes off to an acacia forest and becomes an arahant within the rains. The Buddha, after twice telling Sāriputta to wait, sets out with five hundred monks by the short road through haunted country because the elder Sīvali, the disciple to whom gifts always come, is with them, and spirits feed the whole company at every league. Revata turns the thorn forest into a monastery by psychic power. Two old monks who grumble about favoritism go back for forgotten things and find only acacia thorns, with their belongings hanging on a branch. When they and two young monks give the lay patron Visākhā opposite reports, the Buddha speaks verse 98. The commentary then tells Sīvali's past: a countryman who would not sell his honeycomb for a thousand coins but gave it to a Buddha's feast, and who in a later life, on his mother's advice, starved a besieged city by shutting its little gates. Read the full commentary story, or about Sīvali.



Jornada del Muerto, New Mexico

Nueva Vizcaya and New Mexico, 1672

New Mexico's Franciscan missions depended on supply caravans up the Camino Real from Mexico City, which by royal order left every three years and took about six months each way. The road passed through the silver country of Nueva Vizcaya, where Parral had boomed since the strike of 1631. North of El Paso del Norte the road left the Rio Grande and crossed some ninety miles of almost waterless plain, a route Juan de Oñate chose because it was shorter and easier for ox carts and livestock than the river. It came to be called the Jornada del Muerto after the bones of a German were found along it in 1670. Under canon law a betrothal could be contracted once both children were older than seven.

In the 1670s drought and famine struck the province, Spaniards and Pueblo people alike were reduced to eating hides, and Apache raids increased. The missions rested on Pueblo tribute and labor, and the friars' campaign against Pueblo religion grew harsher; in August 1680 the Pueblos rose together and drove the Spanish out of New Mexico for twelve years (Pueblo Revolt). The catclaw acacia, common in southern New Mexico and Chihuahua, is also called wait-a-minute bush, because a person caught in its hooked prickles has to stop and free himself.

After the story of the Elder Khadiravaniya Revata from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 98 and 412). The original. Scripture from the Latin Vulgate and the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

7.10

The Bell Pool

> *I never found the companion that was so companionable as solitude.*
> *— Thoreau, Walden, "Solitude"*

ok so this is how i heard it, in the chat.

I. The Cards

Rochester, New York · spring 2015

Hollis Tate went live at half past four every morning from the floor of her kitchen on Jefferson Avenue. She propped the phone against two old phone books by the baseboard, turned on the little light over the stove and nothing else, sat down on a folded blanket with her back against the refrigerator, and closed her eyes. That was the broadcast. At six she opened them, read a few of the comments that had piled up on the left side of the screen, and went to work folding hospital sheets at a commercial laundry off Lyell Avenue.

She had started the week the app came out, in March, when the whole internet was pointing its phones at things to see who would watch. The title of every broadcast was the same. *SIT WITH ME. NOBODY HAS TO TALK.* The first morning four people watched for a minute each. By June it was two or three hundred, from Manila and Leeds and Tulsa and a truck stop outside Gallup, and some of them stayed the whole ninety minutes.

There was no sound. Hollis had been Deaf since birth and had gone to the school for the deaf on St. Paul Street from the age of four, and it had not occurred to her to talk into the thing. People wrote to ask whether their phones were broken. After a while they stopped asking, and some of

them wrote that it was the only quiet they got all day, and that in the silence of her kitchen they could hear their own rooms: a refrigerator, a dog's tags, a man coughing through a wall, rain. Hollis could feel the refrigerator hum along her spine. That was all she knew about it.

When people liked a thing on that app they tapped the screen, and little colored hearts rose up the right-hand side of the picture and wobbled and faded at the top. During her sits the hearts went up the edge of her kitchen all the time, pink and green and yellow, a slow column of them past the stove light and the shelf with the salt and the small white figure that people kept asking about. With her eyes shut she never saw them.

Sometimes, at six, she answered a comment by writing on an index card with a black marker and holding it up to the lens. She did not answer many. *YES. DRINK SOME WATER. I DON'T KNOW.* Once, when someone in Ohio wrote that she was lonely, a card that took her a while to letter, copied out of a library copy of *Walden* she had kept since high school and never returned: *I NEVER FOUND THE COMPANION THAT WAS SO COMPANIONABLE AS SOLITUDE.* About the white figure on the shelf, after the fortieth time somebody asked: *A FRIEND GAVE IT TO ME. SHE HEARS EVERYTHING.*

• • •

Mateo Arroyo found her at 4:40 one morning in April in the parking lot of a distribution center on the mountain above Pocono Summit, on his last break of a ten-hour night. He was twenty-six. He picked orders with a scanner gun strapped to his wrist that told him how many seconds he had to reach each bin, and he had been doing it for three years, and the gun had never once said he was fast enough. He was thumbing through whoever was live, a girl doing her makeup in Brazil, a man feeding geese, a car crash, when he hit a dark kitchen with a woman sitting in it, and nothing happening, and no sound.

He watched until his break was over. He went back to the floor and picked till half past four and then drove home to the room he rented in

East Stroudsburg and lay on the bed with the phone on his chest and watched her until she opened her eyes.

After that he sat with her most mornings, in his car at first, then on the floor of his room with his back against the bed the way she did it. He did not know why. He had been raised on Sixth Street in Allentown by a grandmother with a shelf of santos and a mother who worked doubles at the hospital, and he had stopped going to Mass at fourteen, and nothing in his life had been quiet since. In the evenings there was beer, and girls from the warehouse, and the phone. In the morning there was the kitchen in Rochester, and he found he could stand it for longer each time.

In July he typed into the comments, with his thumbs shaking a little, *what should i sit with.* He had read somewhere that teachers gave you a thing.

At six she opened her eyes and scrolled, and stopped, and he saw her look straight down the lens for the first time. She took a card and wrote on it slowly, and held it up.

GO SIT WHERE NOBODY WANTS TO BE. SEE WHAT YOU WANT.

He took a picture of the screen. It was still on his phone a year later, when the phone was in a drawer and he was somewhere else.

II. The Bell Pool

Analomink, Monroe County, Pennsylvania · August 2015

Everybody in Stroud Township knew where nobody wanted to be. Penn Hills had been the best honeymoon resort on Route 447 once, a hundred rooms on five hundred acres, with a ski slope and a golf course and an ice rink and a tiki lounge, and heart-shaped bathtubs in every villa. It had run downhill for thirty years, and in the spring of 2009 the last of its founders died at a hundred and two, and within two months the doors were chained and it turned out the place owed the county more than a million dollars in back taxes. The last paychecks never came. Now the county had it, for the taxes, and kids went up there at night to drink and paint their names on the walls, and men came with bolt cutters for the copper.

Mateo had ten vacation days and took them all at once in the slow week before peak season. He parked his Corolla at a pull-off on 447, walked up the old entrance road past a row of tall streetlights with their globes shot out, and carried in two gallons of water, a sleeping pad, a blanket and the phone, which he meant to leave off.

He slept in a villa at the back with the door kicked in. The bed was round. The carpet went up the walls and over the platform where the heart-shaped tub had been until somebody pried it out for the pipes behind it, and left a red heart-shaped hole in the floor that he walked around in the dark. The ceiling had been mirrors. Most of it had come down in the winters and lay in pieces across the carpet, and at first light every piece held a little square of sky, and some of them, when he lay still and looked, held pieces of each other, and the pieces in the pieces held more.

In the day he sat by the pool. It was shaped like a wedding bell, wide at one end and narrowing to a rounded neck at the other, and the water in it was green and still and so thick with algae that a lawn chair and a shopping cart sat in it like things set into Jell-O. Ferns had come up through the cracks in the deck. He sat on the coping at the narrow end with his legs crossed, facing the pines, where he could hear the trucks downshifting on 447 and the creek beyond them, and he closed his eyes the way she did.

On the second day an old woman came up the entrance road with a folding lawn chair and a plastic grocery bag. She set the chair down by the pool and sat in it and took out a Cool Whip tub of halušky, cabbage and noodles fried in butter, and a fork, and put them on the coping beside him, and a thermos of coffee. She did not ask him what he was doing.

My husband went to deer camp forty years, she said. *I know what a man sitting looks like.*

Her name was Anna Hrabal. She lived in a little house across 447 and had made beds at Penn Hills for thirty-one years, and the last two weeks of her pay had never come either. She came every day at noon after that, and he ate once a day, what she brought, and nothing else. Sometimes

she sat in the chair for an hour and told him things without needing him to answer. She had come down from Freeland as a girl, from the coal patches. She had been eighteen the August the creek came up thirty feet in fifteen minutes after the hurricanes and took the camp on Brodhead Creek, the big house with the families from New Jersey up in its attic, mothers and little ones, thirty-seven of them. That was the year Penn Hills got built over new.

Nobody wants to be anyplace too long, she said, folding her chair. *That's the whole Poconos. Honeymoons. You come for a week and you go home.*

He saw what he wanted. That was the first thing. He had thought it would take longer. He wanted a cigarette, and then he wanted a beer, and then he wanted the phone so badly his hand went to the pocket by itself, and he let it go there and come back. He wanted to be seen sitting. He wanted Hollis to see him sitting. He wanted the girl from receiving with the gold hoops. He wanted to sleep, and when he slept he wanted to be awake. He wanted Anna Hrabal to come at noon and he watched himself wanting it from about eleven on. He wanted all of it the way the gun on his wrist wanted the next bin, and it was the same wanting every time, under the different names, and some afternoons he could almost watch it come up out of nothing and go back into nothing like the bubbles that rose now and then through the green water of the pool.

The phone died on the fourth day. He let it. On the sixth it rained, and he sat in the villa with the mirrors and watched the rain in every one of them. By the eighth his face had gone thin and quiet, and Anna Hrabal looked at him a long time over her thermos and did not say anything at all.

III. The Shoot

Mount Pocono and Route 447 · the ninth day

Danielle Kostelnik served drinks at the casino in Mount Pocono, the one they built where the old Mount Airy Lodge had been. She wore the black uniform with the corset top and carried a tray of comped vodka sodas up and down the slot rows from eight at night un-

TIL FOUR IN THE MORNING, AND SHE WAS GOOD AT IT, AND SHE was tired of it. She was twenty-nine. Her daughter Kayla was seven and lived weekdays with Dani's mother in Hazleton, in the house on Alter Street, where there was a yard and a school that was not falling down.

On the side, under the name Honey Kosta, Dani sold photo sets of herself online. Some months that money was more than the casino money. Now and then, when the money was good and the man seemed all right, she met one in person, and she had rules about that which she kept.

This one called himself a photographer. He had written to her for three weeks from somewhere in north Jersey, polite, with a portfolio of real pictures of real ruins, grain elevators and churches and a hospital in the Catskills. He wanted what he called abandoned glamour. He wanted her in a red heart-shaped tub at Penn Hills at the golden hour, a girl in a ruin, six hundred dollars for the set, and he had sent three hundred up front to show he was serious. They were to meet at half past six at the old sign by the road.

She did her makeup in the Jeep in the pull-off. She put her hair up in a loose twist so she could let it down for the camera when he wanted it down. She had a vintage slip in a garment bag on the back seat, and the blouse she was wearing, white, with too many small buttons, because the buttons photographed well undone.

Half past six. Seven. She texted him. At twenty past seven she texted again and the message did not go through, and when she went to his profile it was gone. She sat behind the wheel and laughed out loud, by herself, in the car.

She had been stood up before. Kayla's father had stood her up for most of a year, and then for good. A boy had left her on a bench at Funfest in Hazleton when she was fifteen, with two cotton candies, and she had eaten both. She had the three hundred dollars, and she had the light, which was coming low and gold through the pines now and laying long shadows across the lot, and she did not want to drive back up the mountain yet and put the corset on.

Somewhere in her mother's house there was a photograph of her parents on their honeymoon in 1984, standing at the narrow end of a swim-

ming pool shaped like a bell. Her mother had feathered hair and her father had his arm around her neck like a headlock. They had divorced when Dani was six.

She got out of the Jeep, and stepped over the chain, and walked in.

IV. The Clapping

Penn Hills · a quarter to eight

THE PLACE WAS WORSE THAN SHE REMEMBERED FROM THE PICtures people posted. Somebody had written *LOVE IS DEAD* in silver paint across the front of the lobby and somebody else had crossed out *DEAD* and written *BLIND*, and somebody else had crossed out *BLIND*. Glass crunched under her flats. She walked down past the villas with their doors hanging, looking into each one, the round beds and the shag on the walls, the heart-shaped holes where the tubs had been. There were no tubs. He would have known that, she thought, if he had ever been coming.

Then she came around the end of the last building and there was the pool, the bell, green as a bottle, and a man sitting at the narrow end of it with his eyes closed.

She stopped. He did not move. He was young and thin and needed a shave, in a grey hoodie with a warehouse logo on it, sitting cross-legged on the concrete lip with his hands in his lap like he was waiting for a bus that would come in a hundred years. A lawn chair stood empty beside him. She looked this way and that. There was nobody else anywhere. The light was on the tops of the pines and nowhere else.

Something in her that had been stood up an hour ago came up into her mouth, light and mean and almost happy. *Look at this,* she thought. *Here is a man.*

She walked around the wide end of the bell and stood across the narrow water from him, eight feet away, close enough that he would hear her flats on the deck. He did not open his eyes. So she began to undo the buttons of the white blouse, slowly, from the top, the way she did for the camera, all the way down. Then she did them up again. Then she undid

them again. She reached up and pulled the pins out of her hair and shook it down over her shoulders, and twisted it back up, and pinned it, and pulled the pins again. Then she clapped her hands, twice, hard, and laughed.

The clap went off the empty villas like a shot. A crow went up out of the pines.

He opened his eyes.

Mateo had been sitting nine days with nothing in him but water and Anna Hrabal's halušky and the slow watching of his own wanting, and he had come to think that it had gone quiet, and it had not gone anywhere. It came up through him all at once, every bit of it, from the soles of his feet. His whole body went hot and then shook. His hands shook in his lap. Sweat broke at his hairline and ran. His heart went like the scanner gun when you were behind, and the woman across the water was undoing a button and laughing at him, and he could not look away and he could not look at her, and every want of the nine days, the cigarette and the phone and the girl with the gold hoops and the beer and to be seen, rolled together into this one and stood up in him like a wave about to break.

What is this, he thought. *What is this. What is this.*

V. Senses Still

Rochester and Analomink · 7:52 p.m.

In Rochester, Hollis Tate came home from the laundry and ate supper standing up and washed the plate, and then stood in her kitchen for a while with the plate in her hand.

The young man from Pennsylvania who always wrote in lower case had not been in the comments for nine days. She had noticed on the third. She did not keep track of people, as a rule; they came and went, and that was the arrangement. But she had given him the card, and she had seen his face in his little round picture, and she had thought about him on the bus.

She put the plate away. She propped the phone on the phone books and sat down on the blanket with her back against the refrigerator and went live at 7:40 in the evening, which she had never done, and closed her eyes.

By the pool in Analomink, the phone on Mateo's folded blanket lit up.

It had been dead five days. He had not charged it; there was nowhere to charge it. It lay face up on the grey wool by his knee and its screen came on white and then showed the notice, the way it always had at half past four in the morning, *@hollis_sits is LIVE*, and then the kitchen. The stove light. The shelf with the salt and the white figure. Hollis on her blanket with her eyes shut, and up the right side of the picture, already, the hearts coming, more of them than he had ever seen at once, a whole slow river of them, rose and green and yellow, going up past the stove.

Dani saw it too. She would say so for the rest of her life, to anyone who asked and to some who did not. She saw the light come up off the ground beside the man and she thought it was a flashlight, and then she saw it was a phone, and a woman in it, a Black woman sitting on a kitchen floor in a cardigan.

Hollis opened her eyes and looked straight down the lens, and she lifted her hands and signed.

Mateo did not know sign language. He knew three signs, which he had looked up in April out of politeness and had never used: *hello*, and *thank you*, and *sorry*. He understood every word she said. He would never be able to explain how. The nearest he came, years later, was that it was like being reminded of something. The words went into him in the order she made them, with her hands moving close to her body and her eyes on his, and he could have written them down afterward letter for letter, and later, in a library, he looked for them and found them, exactly, in a book she had kept since high school.

> *Yet I experienced sometimes that the most sweet and tender, the most innocent and encouraging society may be found in any natural object, even for the poor misanthrope and most melancholy man. There can be no very black melancholy to him who lives in the midst of Nature and has his senses still.*
>
> *— Thoreau, Walden, "Solitude"*

Then she put her hands down in her lap and closed her eyes again.

The wave in him did not break. It went down. It went down the way the creek water goes clear in a jar on a windowsill when you stop shaking it, everything that was stirred up in it settling, slowly, all of it, to the bottom, until you can see straight through. His hands stopped. His heart came back down to a walk. The sweat cooled on his face in the evening air. He looked at the woman across the narrow end of the pool and saw her plainly, a tired woman his age with her hair half down and her blouse half buttoned and mascara starting to go in the heat, who had been stood up, he could see that too, and who was frightened now; and he wanted nothing from her at all. He looked at the pines, which were only pines, and they were the most beautiful thing he had ever seen. He looked at the green water, which was beautiful. He looked at the ferns in the cracked deck, and at the empty lawn chair, and at the heart-shaped holes in the floors of the villas behind her, and none of it needed to be anything else, and neither did he.

Dani had stopped with one button half through its hole. She did it up the rest of the way, and the next, to her throat, without knowing she was doing it.

The young man put his palms together and bowed low over the phone, all the way down, until his forehead almost touched the screen. Then he stood up.

And then, Dani said, and she always said this part plainly and never changed it, he went up. He did not jump. He went up off the coping slowly, standing, with his hands still together, the way a man rises on an escalator, past the top of the dead streetlight, past the tops of the pines where the last of the light was, and then north, over the trees, toward

New York, and she watched him go until she could not tell him from the dark.

The phone lay on the blanket. The screen was black. She picked it up and pressed the button and nothing happened. It was cold, as if it had been dead for days.

VI. The Doorbell Light

Jefferson Avenue, Rochester · the same night

Three hundred and twelve people were watching when Hollis Tate opened her eyes at 7:52 that evening and signed into her phone, and two hundred of them did not know sign, and all of them, afterward, said they had understood it. That was the first thing people argued about. The second thing was the replay. On that app in that year a broadcast stayed up for twenty-four hours and then it was gone, and this one went the way they all went, the next evening, before anyone thought to save it properly. There were screenshots. There was a grainy recording somebody in Leeds made by pointing a second phone at the first. In it you can see her hands move. You cannot see what they say.

She ended the broadcast a little after eight. She was rinsing her cup when the light by the front door began to flash, the lamp her nephew had wired to the doorbell, three long pulses across the kitchen ceiling.

The young man on her porch was barefoot and thin and had not shaved in a long time. He wore a grey hoodie with a warehouse logo on it and smelled of pine and of a pool that needed cleaning. She knew his face from the little round picture. He did not say anything. He knelt on the porch boards, in front of her, and put his two hands over the toes of her house shoes, and bowed his head down to them and stayed there for a while.

Then he got up and made the one sign he was sure of, fingers from the chin out toward her, *thank you*, and went down the steps and along Jefferson Avenue under the streetlights, and Mrs. Lacy across the street, who was on her porch with her fan, said afterward that she had watched him

all the way to the corner and that he had not turned it. He just was not on the sidewalk anymore.

It is a hundred and ninety miles from Analomink to Rochester as the crow flies. The last time anybody looked, there was still no bus.

• • •

Anna Hrabal came up the entrance road at noon the next day with her chair and a Cool Whip tub of pierogi and found his blanket folded square on the coping at the narrow end of the pool, and the pad rolled, and the two water jugs rinsed out and stood upside down to dry, and nobody. She sat in her chair for an hour anyway. Then she ate the pierogi herself.

Dani drove to Hazleton that night instead of to the casino and called in sick from her mother's kitchen, and went in and lay down next to Kayla in the narrow bed with the glow-stars on the ceiling and did not sleep. She kept the three hundred dollars. She never told the story to a customer. She told it to her mother, who said she had been drinking, and to a priest at St. Gabriel's, who did not say that, and years later to Kayla, who believed it.

Some mornings after that, when she got off at four and sat in the Jeep in the employee lot on the mountain with the heater going, she opened the app and found the kitchen in Rochester, the stove light, the woman on her blanket with her eyes closed. She never commented. People asked Hollis about the evening broadcast for a long time, and once, after the hundredth time, Hollis held a card up at six o'clock. *I WAS SITTING.* That was all she ever said about it.

The main building at Penn Hills burned to the ground on the fourth of September, 2017, the third fire in three years. Dani saw it on the news from the casino break room, the lobby going up orange behind the trees on 447. The pool was not on the news. The pool did not burn. It would be there still under the ash and the leaves, green, narrowing to its rounded neck, with a lawn chair standing beside it that somebody had forgotten to take home.

That morning at half past four she found the kitchen in Rochester and watched it until six. Before she closed the app she touched the screen

once, with one finger, and one small heart went up the side of the picture, past the stove light and the white figure on the shelf, slowly, wobbling a little, and out at the top.

Background

The verse

> *Forests are delightful; where the world finds no delight, there the passionless will find delight, for they look not for pleasures.*
>
> Dhammapada 99, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk takes a meditation subject from the Buddha and goes to sit in a run-down pleasure garden. A courtesan who has been stood up by a lover wanders in, sees him alone, and decides to unsettle him: she lets down her undergarment and puts it back on, unbinds her hair and binds it again, claps her hands and laughs, and his whole body floods with excitement. The Buddha, seated far away in his chamber at Jetavana, sees what is happening, sends forth a radiant image of himself, and speaks the verse. The monk becomes an arahant where he sits, rises into the air, and goes to give thanks at the Buddha's feet. Read the full commentary story; the verse comes from the Dhammapada, chapter 7, on the arahant.

Analomink, Pennsylvania

The Poconos and Periscope, 2015

After the Second World War the Pocono Mountains of northeastern Pennsylvania sold themselves as a honeymoon capital, and resorts competed with round beds, mirrored walls and heart-shaped tubs. Penn Hills Resort in Analomink, which began as a tavern in 1944, grew in the 1960s to more than a hundred rooms with a ski slope, golf course, ice rink and a swimming pool shaped like a wedding bell. Its co-founder

died in March 2009 at 102, and within two months the resort closed, owing Monroe County over a million dollars in back taxes; workers' final paychecks were never issued. Copper thieves, floods and vandals did the rest, and on September 4, 2017, the main building burned, the third fire in three years. Brodhead Creek runs past Analomink; in the flood of August 1955 it rose thirty feet in fifteen minutes, and thirty-seven people, mostly mothers and children, died at a camp there. The casino at Mount Pocono where Dani works, Mount Airy, opened in 2007 on the site of the old Mount Airy Lodge.

Twitter launched the live-video app Periscope on March 26, 2015, and released it for Android that May. Viewers could comment in real time and tap the screen to send little hearts floating up the side of the picture. In its first year a broadcast's replay stayed up for twenty-four hours and then vanished; Periscope did not let broadcasts be saved permanently until May 2016. Hollis went to the Rochester School for the Deaf, founded in 1876 on St. Paul Street. Rochester, home also to the National Technical Institute for the Deaf, has been found by NTID researchers to have the largest deaf and hard-of-hearing population per capita among working-age adults of any American city studied.

After the story of a certain woman from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 99). The original. Scripture from Henry David Thoreau, *Walden* (1854). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 8

The Thousands

8.1

Copper Teeth

Amen I say to thee, this day thou shalt be with me in paradise.
— Luke 23:43

Voilà comme je l'ai entendu, on the Bayou Road.

I. The Swamp

The cypress back of New Orleans · spring 1738

The old women on the Bayou Road will tell you there were five hundred of them, less one. The register of the Superior Council says nine. Both are true in their way. Nine men in the cypress back of the city, where the ground goes soft and then goes to water and then goes to something that is neither, could be five hundred when they came out at night. They took hogs from the plantations at Chapitoulas and rice from the barges and powder from wherever powder was. They had a camp on a shell mound in the swamp that nobody could find twice, and a fire that nobody ever saw, and a leader called Jupiter who had run from the Company's plantation across the river so many times that he had stopped counting the times and the King's law had not.

The law was simple. A slave who ran for a month lost his ears and was branded on one shoulder with the lily of France. Twice, the other shoulder, and the cord behind the knee. Three times, death. There was not a man on the shell mound who had both his ears.

One night in March a stranger came through the water to the edge of the firelight and stood there until they saw him. He was tall and the color of a pecan shell, and his back and arms were so crossed with old scars that in the firelight he looked like something woven. When he opened his mouth to speak, his teeth were the color of a new copper sou. Nobody

ever learned why. He said his name was Jean-Baptiste, which was the name the priest had given him, and he said, *Let me live with you.*

They brought him to Jupiter. Jupiter was sitting on a cypress knee mending a net, and he did not stop mending it. He looked at the man a long time. Then he spat into the fire.

No, he said. *Not this one.*

Afterward the young ones asked him why, and Jupiter said a thing they remembered when it came true. *That man would cut off his mother's breast and eat it if somebody paid him. He would open his father's throat and drink. I have seen that look in white men and I have seen it in black ones. Send him back into the water.*

But Pierrot, who was nineteen and Jupiter's right hand and loved by everybody, had taken a liking to the stranger. Jean-Baptiste had carried his load through the trembling ground without being asked. He had cleaned Pierrot's musket and found him the good eels. So Pierrot brought him back to the cypress knee two days later and said, *Papa, this one is a good servant to us. Do him the favor.* And because it was Pierrot asking, Jupiter shrugged and went on mending.

II. The Ladder

New Orleans · April 1738

THE HABITANTS OF CHAPITOULAS GOT TIRED OF LOSING THEIR hogs. They went into the swamp with soldiers from the garrison and dogs and a Choctaw tracker the Council paid in cloth, and on the fourth day they came out with all of them, roped neck to neck, the whole five hundred, the whole nine, Jean-Baptiste walking last.

The Superior Council sat in judgment. It did not take them long. They were runaways, and most of them were runaways for the third time, and they had stolen, and two of them had fired on the King's soldiers. The sentence was that they be hanged by the neck on the square before the church until they were dead, and their bodies exposed.

Then there was a difficulty, which was that there was nobody to hang them.

The colony had had a hangman. It did not have one now. The procureur general walked through the town with the warrant in his hand asking, and the soldiers looked at their boots, and the carpenters who had built the gallows said they were carpenters, and a tavernkeeper said that for a hundred livres he would do it and then, when his wife heard, said that he had been joking. Nobody in New Orleans would put his hands on the rope. It was the kind of thing that stays on a family.

So they went down into the prison and stood in front of Jupiter.

Hang these men, said the procureur, *and you will have your life, and your freedom besides, and a piece of land, and a ration from the King's stores as long as you live.*

Jupiter looked at the men he had lived with on the shell mound, and he looked at Pierrot, who was nineteen, and he said nothing at all, and that was his answer.

They asked the next man and the next. They asked all of them, one by one, down the line of the cell, and every man of them looked at the others and shook his head. They asked Pierrot last but one, and Pierrot laughed at them.

Last of all they asked the scarred one with the copper teeth.

Oui, he said. *Yes, certainly.*

The old women on the Bayou Road say that Pierrot did not look at him after that, not once, not in the cell and not on the cart and not at the foot of the ladder, and that this was harder for Jean-Baptiste than anything Jupiter could have said. But the old women were not there. What is in the register is that on a morning in April 1738 nine men were hanged before the church of Saint Louis, and that a slave called Jean-Baptiste received his letter of freedom from the Council the same week, and two arpents of land on the Bayou Road outside the town, and his ration.

He did it well, for a man who had never done it. He was strong, and he was quick, and he did not hesitate on the ladder. When the last of them, who was Jupiter, had been turned off and had stopped moving, the crowd before the church was quiet for a long time, and then went home.

III. The Four Winds

1738–1765

THAT SUMMER THE GARRISON BROUGHT IN A BAND OF THIEVES from the south, from down the river below the English Turn, where there were deserters living with runaways in the marsh. The Council sentenced them, and again there was the difficulty, and they asked the leader and he refused, and they asked every man in the band and every man refused.

Then somebody on the Council said, *The other day a man hanged nine. Where is he?*

Someone had seen him on the Bayou Road, clearing his land. They sent a soldier, and he came, and they said, *Hang these men and you will be paid,* and he said, *Oui, certainly,* and he did it, and was paid.

After that the Council made it permanent. The executioner of high justice of the colony of Louisiana would have his land and his house on it. He would have thirty livres for a hanging and forty for the wheel and ten for a flogging, and a ration from the King's stores. And because it had always been so in France, the clothes of the men he hanged would be his. Later they brought men in from the west, from across the river and the bayous beyond it, and later from the north, from Pointe Coupée and the Natchez country, and he hanged them all. The old women on the Bayou Road say he hanged five hundred from each of the four winds. The register says what it says. After the bands there were the single ones, one this month and two the next, a soldier who had killed his sergeant, a cook who had put something in a soup, a sailor, a thief of horses, a woman.

The woman was called Babet, and she was a laundress, and she was hanged in the summer of 1741 for setting a fire. At the top of the ladder she looked down at him and said, in front of everybody, *I know your face now. I will come back for you.* He turned her off without a word, the way he did them all.

He lived alone on the Bayou Road. He had married once, a woman from the Company's plantation, and she had left him the first year, saying the bed smelled of other people's coats. He planted orange trees on his land, because orange trees did well in that country, and they did. In

March the whole road smelled of them. He had a copper still, the kind the apothecaries used, and in the spring he made orange-flower water in it, and put it on his face and hands, and pushed the blossoms into the buttonhole of whatever coat he was wearing. The coats were always good coats. They had always belonged to someone.

And every morning a boy came from the King's plantation across the river with his ration: a sack of rice, a pot of milk from the King's cows, and a crock of fresh butter. He cooked the rice in the milk until it was soft, the way they did in France, and put the butter on it, and that was what he ate. People on the road said it was a dish for a child or an invalid. He did not care. It was the softest thing in his life.

Nobody spoke to him who did not have to. At the market on the levee the women took his coins with two fingers, and once a man he did not know walked up to him on the Rue de Chartres and spat in his face, and Jean-Baptiste wiped it off with the lace cuff of a dead man's shirt and walked on. Children threw mud at his door. At Mass he stood alone at the back, by the font, and nobody would take the holy water after him. The Council's clerk, when he paid him, put the coins on the table rather than into his hand.

He was a free man, and he could sign his name, and he had land and orange trees and a coat for every day of the month. He did not think about the men. He was careful not to think about them, the way a man walking on the trembling ground in the swamp is careful where he puts his feet.

Twenty-eight years went by like that.

IV. The Coat

New Orleans · March 1766

THAT WAS THE SPRING NOBODY KNEW WHO THE KING WAS.

Louis had given the colony away to his cousin in Spain, people said, in a treaty, years ago, the way you would give someone a horse you were tired of feeding. Nobody had believed it until the Spanish governor actually came up the river in the first week of March with a sour face and not

enough soldiers to take possession of anything. The flag on the square was still French. The Council still sat. Everybody was waiting to see what would happen, and in the meantime there were three men to be hanged for robbing a ship's purser on the levee and leaving him dead in the mud.

Jean-Baptiste was past sixty by then. He did not know exactly how far past. His hands had begun to shake in the mornings, and his knees did not like ladders.

The first man went well enough. The second man he turned off the ladder and the knot was wrong, and the man did not die. He hung there making a sound. Jean-Baptiste took hold of his legs to pull, the way he had done a hundred times, and his arms had no strength in them, and the man kicked him away. He took hold again. He had to climb back up the ladder in the end and do something to the rope with his hands, which were shaking, and when he came down again the crowd was making a sound too, a low sound, worse than the man's. With the third man it went the same.

The Council met two days later. Jean-Baptiste stood at the back of the room in a blue coat that had belonged to a ship's mate and listened to them talk about him as if he were a mule. *He was quick once. Now he is cruel. It is a disgrace to the King, whichever king it is. We will find another one.* They took his ration away. They let him keep his land, because it had been written down.

That was a Thursday. On Friday morning the boy did not come from across the river with the rice and the milk and the butter. Jean-Baptiste had kept a little of each back, out of an old man's habit, so he cooked the last of the rice in the last of the milk himself, slowly, the way he liked it, and put it on the table under a cloth with the crock of butter beside it. He took the coat he liked best, an old brown one, worn soft at the elbows, which had belonged to a Swiss soldier hanged in 1752 for striking an officer. He cut a handful of orange blossoms. He took the flask of orange-flower water. And he walked down the Bayou Road to where the bayou ran slow and brown under the oaks, and took off his shirt, and bathed.

He had not done that in years, washed his whole body in moving water. The scars on his back stood up in the cold. He scrubbed his arms

with sand. Then he put on the Swiss soldier's coat over a clean shirt, and pushed the blossoms through the buttonhole, and put the orange water on his face and neck and the backs of his hands, and walked home smelling of a garden, and sat down at his table in front of the bowl.

The boy, Toussaint, set a basin of water beside him for his hands. Toussaint was ten. He was an orphan of the smallpox whom the Council had bound to the executioner two years before, to learn the trade, because nobody else in New Orleans would take him, and he did not know yet that there was no trade left to learn.

Jean-Baptiste lifted the cloth from the bowl. The steam came up.

Somebody knocked on the door.

V. The Door

The same morning

Fanchon had been on her knees in the Ursulines' chapel since before light. She was a free woman of color, forty-four years old, a washerwoman by trade, and a member of the congregation the nuns had started for the women of the town, where planters' wives and laundresses and slave women knelt on the same floor and said the same rosary. She taught the catechism to the new ones off the ships on Sunday afternoons, in French and in what she had of Bambara, and she was known for not saying much and for something else that people were careful how they spoke of.

When she got up from her knees that morning she stood a moment in the aisle and asked, the way she always did, *Where should I go today?* And the way it sometimes happened, she saw it: a table on the Bayou Road, a bowl of rice and milk with the steam coming up, a crock of butter, a man in a brown coat with orange flowers in the buttonhole. She knew whose house it was. Everybody knew whose house it was.

She thought, *Will he let me in?*

And she saw that too. So she put on her headcloth and took her basket and walked out through the town gate and down the Bayou Road between the orange trees, and knocked.

When he opened the door and saw her standing there, a woman from the town, from the church, on his step, with her basket on her arm, he did not understand at first what she wanted. Nobody had ever knocked on that door who was not a soldier or a clerk. Then he understood that she had only come, and something went through him that he did not have a name for, it had been so long. He thought, *I have hanged men for twenty-eight years. This is the day they took the rice away. This is the day I cooked it myself. And she is standing at my door.*

He took the bowl from the table and gave it to her. He put her in his one good chair, which had belonged to nobody, which he had bought, and spread the fresh butter on the rice for her with his own spoon, and stood beside her with a palmetto fan and fanned her, because it was warm in the house and he did not know what else to do with his hands.

Fanchon looked at the bowl, and at him. She could see what it cost him. The rice was the last of it; anybody could see that. And he wanted it. He had wanted it since the boy did not come.

Monsieur, she said, *eat your own rice.*

He stood there.

Sit down and eat it, she said. *Toussaint, take the fan and fan him.*

So the old hangman sat down on the bench at his own table in a dead man's coat and ate the rice and milk with the butter on it, every spoonful, slowly, while the boy stood behind him moving the palmetto back and forth, back and forth, and the smell of the orange flowers went around the room. When he was done he wiped his mouth and got up and took the fan back from the boy and went on fanning her, and she let him.

She had brought bread in her basket. She ate a little. When she had finished she folded her hands and began the grace after meals, *Agimus tibi gratias,* and then she began to say a few things to him, plain things, the kind she said to the women off the ships on Sunday.

He could not hear her. He heard her voice, but the words would not stay in him. They ran off him like water off a duck. She stopped.

Monsieur. Where are you?

Madame, he said, *I have done hard things for a long time. I have killed a great many men. When you talk, I see them. I see them on the ladder. I cannot hear you for them.*

Fanchon thought for a while. She knew what she was going to say, and she knew it was not the whole truth, the way you know a bandage is not the whole cure. But you cannot dress a wound that a man will not hold still for.

Did you do it because you wanted to, she said, *or did somebody make you?*

The King made me, he said. *The Council, with the King's warrant. Every one of them, with a paper.*

Well then, said Fanchon. *If that is so, what have you done wrong?*

He sat with that for a moment in the brown coat. It went into him a little way, as far as it could go, the way a peg goes into soft wood. If the woman from the church said so. And for the first time in twenty-eight years the men on the ladder stood back, a little, enough.

Bon, he said. *Go on, madame. Please.*

So she told him about the two thieves who were hanged on either side of Our Lord. One of them mocked, she said. The other one only said one thing. He said it hanging there, at the very end, when there was no time left to do anything good, no time to give alms or go to Mass or make it right with anybody. He had nothing in his hands at all. And here is what he said, and here is what he was told.

> *And he said to Jesus: Lord, remember me when thou shalt come into thy kingdom. And Jesus said to him: Amen I say to thee, this day thou shalt be with me in paradise.*
>
> *— Luke 23:42–43*

This day, said Fanchon. *Not after. This one.*

Jean-Baptiste was quiet a long time. The boy had stopped fanning without either of them noticing. Outside, a mockingbird was going through every song it knew in one of the orange trees, and the blossoms were dropping on the path in the warm air, and he heard it all. He heard each word she had said, as if each one had been set down in front of him

on the table, one at a time, like the coins the Council's clerk would not put into his hand. He did not see the ladder. He did not see anything but the room, and the woman in his good chair, and the boy, and the light coming in the door.

He found that he was very patient. He found that he could wait for whatever was coming, and that it did not matter much what it was.

VI. The Road

The Bayou Road · that afternoon

WHEN SHE ROSE TO GO HE WALKED HER UP THE ROAD TOWARD the town, a little way, the way you walk a guest. He did not take her arm. He walked half a step behind her, in the Swiss soldier's coat with the flowers in it, and people working in their gardens along the road straightened up and stared, the washerwoman from the Ursulines and the hangman, walking together in the middle of the afternoon.

At the bend before the town gate he stopped and bowed to her, a real bow, the way he had seen gentlemen do on the square, and she put out her hand and he took it. It was the first hand anyone had given him in twenty-eight years that was not tied. Then he turned around and walked back toward his house.

The cattle of the town grazed loose on the commons along the Bayou Road, and nobody minded them much. That afternoon there was a young red heifer standing in the road where it ran between two ditches, a pretty thing with a white star, and when Jean-Baptiste came down the road toward her she lowered her head and watched him come.

Toussaint saw it from the door. He said afterward that the old man was looking up into the orange trees and did not see her. He said the heifer came at a trot, then a run, and did not use her horns. She struck him with her shoulder, the whole weight of her, and he went over backward into the ditch, and his head struck the edge of a cypress stump that had been there since before the town, and he did not get up. The heifer stood over him for a moment. Then she went off across the commons at a walk, and nobody ever claimed her.

Toussaint ran and got down in the ditch with him. The old man was on his back in the brown coat with the orange blossoms still in the buttonhole and his copper teeth showing, and his eyes were open, and there was nothing in his face at all. No fear. Nothing waiting. Toussaint said it looked like the face of a man listening to someone tell him something good.

The old women on the Bayou Road say the heifer had Babet's eyes. They say it the way they say everything, as if it were not their business whether you believe it.

VII. The Congregation

The Ursuline chapel · the following Sunday

The women of the congregation met after Vespers on Sunday as they always did, and nobody could talk about anything else.

Fanchon was in his house. Fanchon ate at his table.

Twenty-eight years he hanged people on that square. They took away his rice on Thursday. Friday he gave it to Fanchon, Friday he heard the catechism, Friday a cow killed him in the road. All in one day.

And where is he now? said a planter's wife, a pious woman who had lost a brother at Natchez. *Tell me that. Where does a man like that go?*

Nobody said anything. They all looked at the oldest of them.

Her name was Marguerite, and she belonged to the nuns. She had come off a ship from Senegal before the town had a church, and she had taught Fanchon her prayers thirty years before, and the Ursulines themselves asked her things. She was so old that she sat on the floor against the wall during the meetings, with her legs out straight in front of her, and nobody thought it was strange.

He went where the thief went, she said.

The thief on the cross asked, said the planter's wife. *He had faith. This man heard a grace after meals and a few words from a washerwoman. Forgive me, Fanchon. A few words.*

Twenty-eight years, somebody else said. *And a few words.*

Marguerite looked at them for a while from the floor, one at a time, the planters' wives in their silk and the laundresses with their sleeves still damp and the slave women off the ships who did not have enough French yet to follow and were watching her face instead. She took her time.

Don't weigh it, she said. *You are not the one who weighs it. You hear sermons every Sunday, an hour long, and you go home the same. He heard one thing, and it was the right thing, and he went quiet. That is all a word is for.* And she said it to them the way the priest read it out of Solomon.

> *The words of the wise are heard in silence, more than the cry of a prince among fools.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 9:17*

Then she closed her eyes, which meant the meeting was over.

• • •

They buried him at the back of the cemetery, along the fence, where they put the ones nobody would claim. Fanchon paid the gravedigger. She and the boy were the only ones there, and the boy, who had nowhere now to go, went home with her and learned to wash linen instead.

The Council found his coats in a chest in the house, twenty-eight years of them, the coats of soldiers and sailors and thieves and cooks, and one dress, a laundress's, folded at the bottom. Nobody would buy them. In the end the Ursulines took them for the poor, and that winter you could see them all over New Orleans, on the levee and in the market and on the Bayou Road, the dead men's coats walking around on living men who did not know whose they were.

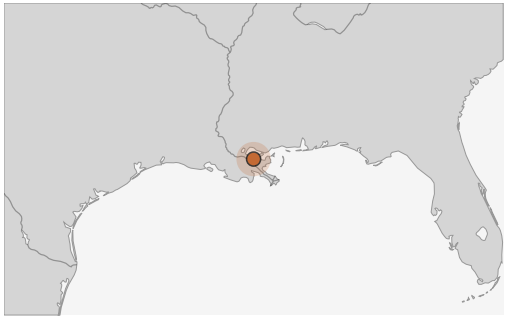
The orange trees went on blooming on his two arpents for years after the house fell in. Every March the whole road smelled of them, and people going in and out of the town gate would stop and break off a sprig for the buttonhole, without thinking whose trees they were, and walk on.

Background

The verse

> *Even though a speech be a thousand (of words), but made up of senseless words, one word of sense is better, which if a man hears, he becomes quiet.*
>
> Dhammapada 100, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a scarred man with copper-colored teeth joins a band of thieves whose leader distrusts him on sight. When the band is captured, no one will act as executioner, and every thief refuses the offer of his life in exchange for killing his companions, until the newcomer agrees. He becomes the city's executioner for fifty-five years. When he is dismissed in old age for bungling his work, he prepares the milk-porridge he will no longer be given, bathes, and dresses in the old clothes, flowers and perfume that came with the post. At that moment the elder Säriputta comes to his door. The man gives him the porridge; the elder tells him to eat it himself, then asks whether he killed of his own will. *The king made me. Then what wrong did you do?* His mind grows calm and he listens. Walking home, he is killed by a cow, and the Buddha tells the doubting monks that he has gone to a heavenly world, because one word that brings peace is worth more than a thousand. Read the full commentary story, or about Säriputta.



New Orleans, French Louisiana

New Orleans, 1738–1766

French Louisiana ran on the Code Noir, which Louis XV extended to the colony in 1724. Under the code, an enslaved person who ran away for a month lost his ears and was branded with a fleur-de-lis; a second time, the hamstring was cut and the other shoulder branded; a third time meant death (the text). The colony struggled to find anyone who would carry out its sentences. In 1725 the Company of the Indies freed an enslaved man named Louis Congo and made him public executioner, with land outside New Orleans, a ration, and a fee for each flogging, hanging or breaking on

the wheel. He was attacked at least twice, and the records of him stop after 1737. Jean-Baptiste, his band and the people of this story are invented.

The Ursuline nuns arrived in 1727. Their convent on Chartres Street, rebuilt between 1748 and 1753, still stands. The nuns taught the catechism to enslaved women with great success, and in 1730 they sponsored a laywomen's confraternity whose members ranged from plantation mistresses to women of color. By the 1730s orange and citron trees were doing well in New Orleans. In 1762 France ceded Louisiana to Spain, and the first Spanish governor, Antonio de Ulloa, arrived in March 1766 without the troops to take control. After the colonists drove him out in the Rebellion of 1768, General Alejandro O'Reilly condemned its leaders to hang. According to an early history of the colony, no hangman could be found in all of Louisiana, so the five men were shot.

After the story of Tambadāṭhika, the copper-toothed executioner, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 100). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.2

The King's Bowl

Be still and see that I am God.
— Psalm 45:11

Ainsi l'ai-je ouï dire, at the Straits.

I. The Plank

Lake Huron · November 1744

Eight men went into the lake in the third week of November, and one came out.

They were Albany men, Dutch and English, with a north canoe they had bought from somebody who should not have sold it and a load of stroud blankets, powder and rum they meant to carry up past the French to the Odawa towns, where the Odawa would pay in beaver for English cloth, which they liked better than anything that came up from Montreal. France and England had been at war since the spring. Everybody on the lakes knew it. The men in the canoe knew it too, but they believed the lake was too big for a war to find them in. A northwest gale found them instead, at dusk, among the islands below the Straits, and put the canoe on a shoal and broke her back, and the water took them one at a time, the way cold takes the fingers.

Pieter Schenck got his arms over a length of the broken gunwale and held on. He held on through the dark and the snow squalls and a cold so great that after a while it stopped being cold and became a kind of sleep he had to keep climbing out of. He was twenty-four. He came from the Raritan valley in the Jerseys, where his people had farmed since the Dutch had the country, and he had never meant to come west at all. Toward morning the gunwale grounded on gravel. He crawled up out of the

shallows and lay on the stones of a beach and saw, up the shore, the gray points of a stockade and smoke going up from inside it into a white sky.

The lake had taken his shirt and his breeches and one shoe. He threw the other shoe away. There was a paper birch lying on the beach where some earlier storm had laid it down, and he peeled the bark off it in sheets with his fingers and his teeth and wrapped himself in it, and broke cedar boughs and wrapped those over the bark, and bound the whole thing on him with spruce root he pulled out of the sand. Then he walked up the beach to the gate of Fort Michilimackinac.

He knew, as soon as the sentry called down to him, that he could not answer. He had trading French, enough to buy and sell, but he spoke it the way Albany spoke it, and any Frenchman on the Straits would hear the English king in his mouth. So he stood at the gate and said nothing. The sentry called again. Pieter looked up at him and said nothing. The sentry looked at the bark and the cedar and the cut bare feet on the frozen ground, and at the face above it, and slowly took his hat off.

They brought him into the King's storehouse because it had the stove. The storekeeper took a wooden bowl off the shelf, a plain turned bowl out of the King's stores like a hundred others, and filled it with sagamité from the pot, hominy boiled soft with bear's grease, and put it in his hands. Pieter ate it without a word. The storekeeper's wife stood in the door with a child on her hip and watched him eat, and when he was done she said, very low, to nobody in particular, *He came up out of the lake.*

II. The Saint

Michilimackinac · winter 1744–1745

The Jesuit was away all that winter at L'Arbre Croche, among the Odawa, and there was nobody at the Straits to ask the man in bark any hard questions. So the fort answered them for itself. He had come out of the lake in November, when nobody comes out of the lake. He wore bark like Saint John in the wilderness. He did not speak, which meant he was under a vow, which meant he was a holy man of some order nobody at the Straits had heard of, a hermit maybe, from the far missions

of the West, cast up among them for a reason. By Christmas the soldiers' wives were calling him *le saint homme*, the holy man, and the voyageurs who had stayed the winter called him *l'Homme d'Écorce*, the Bark Man, which was easier to say.

He lived in a lean-to of poles and bark against the back of the new church of Sainte-Anne, which smelled of fresh-cut cedar. People brought him things. Smoked whitefish from the Straits, which were the best whitefish in the world. Sagamité in his bowl, morning and night. Cakes of maple sugar wrapped in bark. A soldier brought him a twist of tobacco, and a girl brought him a capot, a good hooded coat cut from a blanket, and he looked at it a long time and gave it back to her. A man in a capot was only a man. Nobody walked through the snow to bring whitefish to a man in a capot.

Women brought him their sick children, and he did not know what else to do, so he put his hand on their heads. Some of the children got well. Children do. A soldier asked him to bless his musket and he made the sign of the cross over it, which he had seen the French do a thousand times and never done in his life, because in the Raritan valley they would have called it papistry. The soldier kissed his hand. Then all of them did. *Le saint homme.* He let them.

At night in the lean-to, alone, he asked himself the question that every man and woman in the Raritan valley had been asking for twenty years.

There had been a dominie on the Raritan who preached the new birth. Pieter had grown up on his sermons, two hours long, and on the catechism, a hundred and twenty-nine questions with their answers, and on the psalms in Dutch rhyme, all hundred and fifty, which his mother sang over the churn. Everyone on the Raritan knew all the words. The question was whether the words had gone in. Was the work of grace begun in you? Were you born again, or only baptized? Could you name the hour? People wept in the meetinghouse over it. People lay awake. Pieter had lain awake.

Now he lay awake in the bark lean-to, with whitefish in his belly that had been given to him in love, and asked it again, and for the first time the answer seemed to him to be yes. Perhaps this was how it came. Per-

haps the lake had done it. The cold and the silence and the bark. Perhaps these people knew something about him that he did not, and he really was what they said.

• • •

There had been seven of them once, seven boys, the summer he was sixteen, in the high fever after a sermon. They had sworn together on the meetinghouse steps that they would get the new birth or die, and they had carried a ladder up the First Mountain to a ledge of rock above the valley, and climbed it, and kicked the ladder down, so that nobody could go back who had not got what they came for.

The first night, Cornelis, who was the oldest, got it. They all saw it happen. He knelt on the rock in the dark and something went through him like a wind through standing wheat, and he got up laughing. He went down the cliff the hard way, by the roots, and came back up at dawn with bread and a jug of milk and set them on the rock and said, *Eat.* They would not. They had not sworn to eat the bread of the first one through, they said. When they had it themselves they would get their own bread. On the second night it was Dirck, who was quiet and fourteen, and something happened to him too, though not so much as to Cornelis, and he went down and brought bread, and they would not eat his either. Every man finds his own bread.

The other five lay on the rock until the seventh day, when their fathers came up the mountain with a new ladder and carried them down, half-starved and raving, and the dominie preached on them the next Sunday as a warning against enthusiasm. Cornelis died of the smallpox two winters later, still smiling. Dirck went to sea and was lost off Sandy Hook. Pieter came away from the rock with nothing but the rule they had made up there, and he had kept it ever since. In eight years he had not given any man so much as the heel of a loaf, nor asked for one, and he was proud of it. Every man finds his own bread.

Except that here at the Straits he had been fed all winter by strangers, and had called it grace.

III. Dirck

The Straits · April 1745

The ice went out of the Straits in the third week of April, and on the first night it moved, Pieter woke in the lean-to to a sound like cannon. It was the ice. Whole fields of it were splitting and riding up on one another and grinding east toward Lake Huron in the dark. He went out to look, through the water gate, onto the beach where he had come ashore.

Dirck Hoogland was standing over the ice.

He was not on it. He stood a man's height above it, on nothing, in the blue shirt he had been wearing when the sea took him, with his hair wet and his feet bare, and he was fourteen still, and very quiet, exactly as he had been on the rock. The ice moved under him and he did not move with it. Afterward the sentry who was on the bastion that night told it in every tavern from the Straits to Montreal, and he said the same thing every time and never added to it: *There was a boy standing on the air.*

Pieter, said Dirck. *You aren't what they say. You aren't anywhere near it. You aren't even on the road that goes to it. What you're doing will take you the other way.*

Pieter stood on the gravel in his bark. The shame went through him like the cold had gone through him in the lake, all the way in.

Then is there anybody? he said, and it was the first time he had spoken out loud since November, and his voice came out cracked and strange. *Is there anybody on this earth who really is what they call me?*

At Le Détroit, said Dirck. *There's an old man of the Hurons. The Black Robes baptized him Thomas. In the mornings, when he comes up to the fort, he goes about among the houses. He is what you want to be. Go to him.*

Then he was not there. The ice went on grinding.

Pieter went that night. It is a hundred leagues and more from the Straits to Le Détroit, down the whole long shore of Lake Huron and through the little lake and down the river, ten days for a brigade of good paddlers in summer, and he had no canoe, and the ice was going out. The sentry saw him go along the beach after midnight, south, at a walk, in his

bark. The Huron men camped at the landing below Le Détroit saw him come up the river road at sunrise. Nobody ever settled what happened between. The women at the Straits said afterward that Dirck carried him. The Hurons at Bois Blanc said that the old man had called him and that when Thomas calls, the road gets short. Pieter Schenck himself never said, because there was not time.

IV. The River Gate

Le Détroit · the next morning

The Huron canoes were drawn up on the strand below the stockade, three of them, with bags of seed corn in them for the habitants, and a half dozen young men from the mission at Bois Blanc were walking up and down on the beach in the early sun to get the stiffness of twenty miles of paddling out of their legs. They stopped when they saw him. He came up the river road with the bark hanging off him in strips and the cedar gone, and his feet bleeding through a crust of mud and ice.

Where is the old man? he said. *Thomas.*

The oldest of them, a man about Pieter's own age with a brass crucifix on a thong at his throat, looked at him for a while before he answered. *He has gone in among the houses. He'll be back down to the canoes at noon.* And then, because the man in front of him was swaying on his feet, *Where have you come from?*

From Michilimackinac.

When did you leave Michilimackinac?

Last night.

The young men looked at one another. Nobody laughed. One of them had a kettle of sagamité going on a little fire on the beach, and he dipped some into a bark dish and held it out.

You've come a long way, then, said the one with the crucifix. *Sit down. Eat. Wash your feet in the river and let us grease them. He'll be here at noon and you'll see him.*

I don't know when he is going to die, said Pieter. *I don't know when I'm going to die. I came here in one night and didn't sit down once. I'll sit down when I've seen him.*

And he went up the strand and in at the river gate, shaking all over, the way a horse shakes at the end of a hard run.

V. Sainte-Anne Street

Inside the stockade · the same morning

Le Détroit was smaller than he had imagined, a square of log palisade with a bastion at each corner, the little church at one end, and four or five streets so narrow two carts could hardly pass. Rue Sainte-Anne ran along the south wall. It was mud from one end to the other, April mud, with planks laid across the worst of it, and smoke coming down into it from the public bake house, which had been firing since before light, so that the whole street smelled of bread.

The old man was coming up it from the bake house with a basket on his arm.

Pieter knew him at once, though he could not have said how. He was old, and not tall, and there was nothing about him that anyone would turn to look at twice. He wore a blanket capot like any habitant, and leggings, and moccasins black with mud, and a brass crucifix like the young man's at the landing. His hair was white and cut short. He walked the way a man walks who is going somewhere ordinary and is not in a hurry to get there, and he looked at what was in front of him, the planks and the mud and the dog asleep in the door of the smithy, as if each of them was all there was.

Pieter went down on his knees in the mud of the street and put his face down near the old man's feet and took hold of him by both ankles.

Teach me, he said. *Teach me what's true. For the love of God. So it'll be to my good as long as I live.*

Thomas looked down at him. A habitant woman going by with a pail stopped and stared. Two soldiers in the door of the guardhouse stopped and stared.

Not now, said Thomas. *I've gone in among the houses.*

He said it kindly, the way you say it to a child who has run up to you in the middle of an errand. Pieter did not let go of his ankles. He was shaking so hard that the old man could feel it through the leggings.

Please. I don't know when you'll die. I don't know when I'll die. Teach me.

Not now, said Thomas again.

The people of Le Détroit who saw it said afterward that the old man had been hard with the stranger, and the young men at Bois Blanc, who knew Thomas, said that was foolishness. A man who has come a hundred leagues in a night, they said, has the whole road still running in him. He is so full of the journey and the hope and the fear that nothing anybody says can get in. So Thomas waited. He stood in the mud with his basket and let the man hold his ankles and shake, and he waited for the shaking to go down, the way you wait for a river to clear after rain before you dip your bucket in it.

The third time Pieter asked, his voice was quiet.

I don't know the hour you'll die, or the hour I will. Teach me.

Thomas set the basket down on a plank. He did not kneel. He stood where he was in the middle of rue Sainte-Anne, with the smoke of the bake house going over the two of them and the soldiers watching, and said it to him in French, slowly, in the plain words of a man who had worked a long time to find them.

Then this is it, Pieter Schenck. When you see, let there be only the seeing. When you hear, only the hearing. When a thing touches you, only the touch. When a thought comes, only the thought. Don't go in after it. If you don't go in after it, you aren't in it. If you aren't in it, you aren't here, and you aren't there, and you aren't anywhere in between. That is the end of the trouble. That's the whole of it.

Pieter had not told him his name.

He was looking at the mud. There was mud, brown, shining where the sun was on it, with the print of a moccasin in it filling slowly with water. There was the smell of bread. There was the bell of Sainte-Anne beginning, one stroke, then another, and between the strokes a cow lowing somewhere out on the commons past the palisade. There was a cold that

was the wet coming through the bark at his knees. There was the dog asleep in the smithy door. Every one of them came, and was itself, and went, and nothing went in after them.

And there was nobody kneeling in the street.

There was no holy man of the Straits there, and no Albany trader hiding his English, and no boy on a ledge on the First Mountain waiting for the wind that went through Cornelis. All of them had been things he had gone in after. All of them had been a kind of bark. The bark was down in the mud now with the rest of the morning, and there was nobody inside it, and there had never been, and the whole of his trouble went out of him at once, the way the ice had gone out of the Straits, with a great noise and then a great quiet.

Thomas picked up his basket. He said one more thing before he went on, in the tone a man uses for amen.

> *Be still and see that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, and I will be exalted in the earth.*
>
> *— Psalm 45:11*

Pieter got up out of the mud.

Let me come with you, he said. *Let me come down to the mission and be one of you. Let me be baptized again the way you were.*

Thomas looked him up and down. The bark. The bare legs. The bowl from the King's storehouse, which he had carried all night inside the bark against his chest without knowing it, and which was all he had.

Have you got your own blanket? said Thomas. *Your own bowl?*

The bowl is the King's.

Then go and get your own, said Thomas. *And come down to the canoes at noon.*

And he went on up rue Sainte-Anne with his basket, toward the houses at the other end, where they were waiting for him.

VI. The Bread Board

The commons · the same morning

The young men at Bois Blanc talked about it for years afterward, and what they said was this. Thomas could have given the man a blanket. There were two in the canoes. He could have stood in the street and said the words the Black Robes said and made him one of them on the spot. He did not, because he knew what Pieter had done on the rock. In eight years, Pieter Schenck had never given a soul so much as a crust. Every man finds his own bread. A man who has lived that way a long time finds there is no blanket waiting for him anywhere, because he has never left one anywhere for anyone else. Thomas could not change that for him. Nobody could. So he sent him to go and find his own.

Pieter went out at the east gate onto the commons, where the cattle of the fort were turned out in spring, to look for a birch to peel. He was not unhappy. He had the King's bowl in his hand. He was looking at the commons the new way, the brown grass, the wet, a crow, and there was nobody looking.

There was a cow standing by the dung heap outside the gate.

She was a red heifer, alone, with a white star on her forehead, and nobody saw where she came from. She put her head down and came at him across the wet ground, not fast, and turned at the last moment and struck him with her left shoulder, the whole weight of her, the way a door swings shut, and he went down on the dung heap and his head struck the frozen edge of it, and he did not get up.

No habitant of Le Détroit ever claimed her. Every cow on that commons was known by name and by owner and by the marks on her ears, and none of them was a red heifer with a white star, and by noon she was gone and nobody had seen her go. The soldiers' wives at the Straits, when the story came up to them in June, said they knew that cow. They had seen her in November, the week the canoe went down, standing alone in the shallows below the fort where nobody at Michilimackinac kept cattle, looking out at the lake.

• • •

Thomas came out of the east gate a little before noon with his basket full of loaves and the young men from the canoes behind him, and saw the body lying on the dung heap in the sun.

He stood and looked at it for a long time. Then he said, *Go to the bake house. There is a long board that stands by the door, that the baker carries loaves on. Ask him for it. Tell him I asked.*

They brought the bread board, and laid Pieter Schenck on it, bark and all, with the King's bowl on his chest, and carried him on their shoulders out past the commons and the last of the farms. He could not lie in the burying ground of Sainte-Anne. Everyone knew by then what he was, an Englishman, a heretic, a Dutchman from the Jerseys; the soldiers at the guardhouse had heard his French. So they carried him up onto a rise above the river where the oaks were, and dug, and laid him in, and the young men heaped stones over the place against the wolves, a long heap, higher than a man's knee. Thomas cut a cross out of cedar and tied it with spruce root and stood it at the head of the stones. He did not take the bowl. He put it in the basket, under the bread.

The commandant's clerk wrote in his book that an English stranger, name unknown, had been killed by a cow on the commons. Thomas could have told him the name. Nobody asked him.

VII. The King's Bowl

Bois Blanc Island · that night, and the summer after

They paddled back down to the mission in the afternoon with the seed corn sold and the bread in the bottom of the canoe, and that night, after the prayers, the young men sat around the fire outside Thomas's lodge and could not leave it alone.

Where has he gone, the man in the bark?

To God, said Thomas. *All the way. He won't be coming back around.*

An Englishman? A heretic who never had the sacraments, who lay on the Straits all winter letting people kiss his hand?

Yes.

But when did he get there?

When he heard me.

When did he hear you?

This morning. In the street. Outside the bake house.

The one with the brass crucifix shook his head. *Grandfather, you hardly said anything to him. We were watching from the gate. You said four or five words to him, standing in the mud with a basket on your arm. The Black Robes preach for an hour. How could a man get all the way to God on four or five words?*

Thomas was quiet for a while. The fire settled. Out on the dark river a fish jumped, and the rings went out across the water and were gone.

Don't measure it by how long it was, he said. *Some men hear a thousand words and every one of them is empty. You can preach to a man from now till the Feast of All Saints and nothing goes in. Then one word with something in it, and he hears it, and he's quiet.* And he said it to them as Saint Paul had said it, which the Black Robe had taught him years before at the old mission, and which he had kept.

> *But in the church I had rather speak five words with my understanding, that I may instruct others also; than ten thousand words in a tongue.*
>
> *— 1 Corinthians 14:19*

I've seen a great many come to the prayer, Thomas said. *Old men, children, French, Hurons, Odawa, Englishmen. That one was the quickest of all of them. Nobody I ever saw was quicker.*

Some of the young men who sat at that fire were old men themselves forty years later, on the Sandusky and in the Ohio country and across the river at La Pointe de Montréal, and they still told it. They said it was the night they first understood what the old man had been trying to tell them all their lives.

• • •

In June the first brigade of the summer went up from Le Détroit to the Straits, and Thomas went down to the landing and found a voyageur he knew and gave him the wooden bowl wrapped in a piece of bark.

Take this to the storekeeper at Michilimackinac, he said. *Tell him it belongs to the King.*

The voyageur carried it three hundred miles up the lake in the bottom of his canoe and gave it to the storekeeper, and told him whose it had been. The storekeeper turned it over in his hands. Then he put it up on the shelf with the others.

The soldiers' wives came in that week to see it, the bowl of *le saint homme*, and stood in front of the shelf a long time, and could not tell which one it was. They were all plain turned bowls out of the King's stores, a hundred of them, all alike. By the first snow some soldier on the night watch was eating his sagamité out of it on the bastion, looking out over the dark water, and did not know, and it did not matter.

Background

The verse

> *Even though a Gatha (poem) be a thousand (of words), but made up of senseless words, one word of a Gatha is better, which if a man hears, he becomes quiet.*
>
> Dhammapada 101, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Bāhiya Dārucīriya, "the man from abroad who wears bark," is the only survivor of a shipwreck. He wraps himself in bark, is fed and honored as a saint at the port of Suppāraka, and comes to believe it. A former companion, one of seven monks who long ago climbed a mountain and kicked the ladder down behind them, comes from the Brahma world to tell him he is no such thing. Bāhiya goes to the Buddha in a single night and begs three times in the street to be taught. When he hears "in the seen, only the seen," he is awakened on the spot. Sent off to find his own bowl and robe, he is killed by a cow that the commentary says was a demoness. The Buddha has his body carried out on a litter, burned, and a stūpa built over it, and names him foremost of those who understand quickly. Read the full commentary story, or the Bāhiya Sutta, where the teaching appears in full.

Michilimackinac and Detroit, New France (Michigan)

The upper Great Lakes, 1744-1745

The French built Fort Michilimackinac around 1715 on the Straits of Mackinac, where Lakes Michigan and Huron meet, and it became the main depot of the fur trade in the upper Great Lakes. In 1742 the Odawa moved about twenty-five miles south to L'Arbre Croche, and the Jesuits moved their mission with them. In 1743 a new parish church of Sainte-Anne went up inside the stockade (see the Mackinac State Historic Parks timeline). In the spring of 1744 France and Britain went to war again. In the colonies this was King George's War, and English-speaking traders on the lakes were enemies. Pieter's people belonged to the Dutch Reformed world of the Raritan valley in New Jersey, where Theodorus Frelinghuysen had preached the new birth since the 1720s. Children there learned the 129 questions of the Heidelberg Catechism.

Cadillac founded Fort Pontchartrain du Détroit in 1701 as a log palisade about twelve feet high, with a bastion at each corner. Its first building was a chapel to Saint Anne. Wendat people, whom the French called Hurons, came down from Michilimackinac to settle near it. They descended from Wendat and Petun refugees scattered by the wars of 1649, and today they are the Wyandot and Wendat nations. A Jesuit mission to them was founded at Detroit in 1728. In 1742 Armand de La Richardie moved it about twenty miles downriver to Bois Blanc Island, and Pierre Potier arrived there in September 1744 after studying the Huron language. In the unrest of 1747 the mission was destroyed. It was rebuilt across from the fort at La Pointe de Montréal, which is now Windsor, Ontario. Thomas and his people are fictional, as are Pieter, the bowl and the cow.

After the story of Bāhiya Dārucīriya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 101). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.3

The Branch

> *Nanak, only one word, God's name, would be of account; all else would be the senseless discussion of pride.*
> *— Asa ki War*

Main inj suniā hai, on the Guide Meridian.

I. The Window

Lynden, Washington · August 2008

Mohinder Singh Gill had six hundred acres of raspberries north of Lynden, a cold storage on the Badger Road, and a house on the Guide Meridian three stories high, the tallest house between Bellingham and the Canadian line. He had come down from Abbotsford in 1986 with a used tractor and a loan from his wife's brother, with forty acres he could barely afford, and he had paid back every dollar and bought every farm that came up for sale on his road. Two-thirds of the raspberries in America came out of that county, and a good share of them came out of his fields. He was proud of that. He said so at the gurdwara, where he gave a great deal of money, and at the Rotary, where he gave a little.

His daughter Simran had the whole top floor. She was eighteen, just out of high school, and the most beautiful girl in the Punjabi families from Surrey to Mount Vernon, and her father knew it, and knew what the world was, so the top floor was where she stayed. She had gone to school in Lynden and come straight home. She went to the gurdwara with her mother and sat with the women. In the summers, when the pickers came and the cousins came and the house was full, her father's sister Jaswinder came down from Surrey and slept in the room next to hers, and Bhua Jaswinder did not sleep much.

On a hot afternoon in August, Simran heard shouting from the fields and went to the window.

Two Whatcom County deputies were walking a young man out of the raspberry rows toward the road. His hands were cuffed behind him and his white T-shirt was torn half off and there was blood on his face. Somebody had been stealing copper all summer, stripping the wire out of the irrigation pumps on the farms along the Guide at night and selling it for scrap in Bellingham, and that afternoon old Sohan Singh Dhillon had caught him at it in broad daylight, and the young man had hit him with a length of pipe and run, and the pickers had run him down in the rows. They lined the farm road now, the pickers and the foremen and the neighbors who had come out at the noise, and at every turn of the road, as the deputies brought him past, somebody yelled at him in Punjabi or in Spanish or in English, and somebody held a phone up to film him, and he turned his face from each one like a man being struck.

He was tall. He had cut his hair. Even from the top floor she could see he was from a good family, by the way he walked between the deputies with his back straight, as if they were escorting him somewhere he had been invited.

She knew him. Everybody knew him, or about him. Rajbir Sandhu, Raj, from Abbotsford, whose father owned a trucking company, who had gone to university in Vancouver for one year and come home and lost everything his father gave him at the casinos down the I-5, and then gone on losing. This was his third time in front of a judge in Washington. A third strike in Washington meant prison until you died.

She stood at the window until the deputies' car was gone. Then she lay down on her bed and did not get up.

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She would not eat. Her mother brought her parathas and she turned her face to the wall. Bhua Jaswinder brought her chai and sat on the end of the bed and talked for an hour, and Simran did not answer.

What is it, beta? What is it? Tell me.

The one they walked out of the field. Raj. If I get him, I'll live. If I don't, I'm going to lie here until I die.

Don't talk like this. We'll find you a boy. A good boy, a doctor, our kind of family. Your father has had calls already, from Surrey, from Yuba City.

I don't want anybody else. If I can't have him, I'll die.

On the fourth day her mother went down to the office in the cold storage and told her father, and on the fifth day her father climbed the stairs to the top floor, which he had not done in years, and stood in the door and looked at her, and saw that she meant it. He went out to the porch and sat until it was dark.

She never knew exactly what he did. She never asked. There was money, a great deal of it, and some of it went to a man who knew a man in the county, and some of it went to old Sohan Singh Dhillon, who found he could not be certain after all who had hit him with the pipe. The case against Rajbir Sandhu went away. In the spring, a drifter from Skagit County who already had two strikes and had sold some copper of his own in Bellingham that summer was convicted of the whole thing and went to Walla Walla for the rest of his life, and nobody on the Guide Meridian ever said his name.

II. The Promise

The Guide Meridian · 2008–2009

They were married in November at the gurdwara, under the canopy, and walked the four laavan around the Guru Granth Sahib while the ragis sang, and Raj walked ahead of her as the groom does, with the end of her scarf in his hand, and the whole Punjabi Northwest came and ate and went home talking. Mohinder Singh gave them a house on one of the farms.

Simran meant to be a good wife. She meant it with everything she had. Every evening she put on her gold, the heavy wedding set her mother had given her, the necklace and the earrings and the bangles, twenty-two karat, and cooked his dinner with her own hands in it, so that he would see her in it. She did not know any other way to say it.

It was the gold he looked at.

Before the winter was out he was thinking about it every night. Two hundred thousand dollars of gold, maybe more, walking around his kitchen. One of these days, he thought, she would have to take it off, and he could take it to a jeweler he knew in Surrey who asked no questions, and then he could eat dinner at the casino every night for a year and never come home. But she would never take it off while she was alive.

He thought about that, and then he saw how to do it.

In April he took to his bed. He would not eat. She came to him with a plate.

Are you sick?

No.

Is it my father? Has he said something to you?

Your father has been good to me.

Then what is it?

He turned his head on the pillow and looked at her a long time before he said it.

When they walked me out of that field, he said, *with my hands behind me, and everybody filming, I prayed. I never prayed in my life before that. I made a sukhna. I promised Waheguru, if I got free of this, if I got that girl in the top window, I would carry karah prashad up to the highest place I could find and give thanks there where I could see the whole world. And I got free. And I got you. And I never paid it. That's what's eating me.*

She sat down on the bed and took his hand. *Don't worry. Don't worry about anything. I'll make it. Tell me what to make.*

Karah prashad, the real way, with ghee. Honey in it. And flowers. Five kinds. Marigolds, and whatever else you can find.

She made the karah prashad herself in the big iron pan, flour and ghee and sugar and a jar of honey from the beekeeper on the Badger Road, stirring it until her arm ached, the way her grandmother had shown her, and put it in a steel dabba wrapped in a clean cloth. She bought marigolds at the Indian grocery in Surrey, and daffodils from the stand on the Guide, and tulips from the Skagit fields, which were just opening,

and lilac from her mother's bush, and a sprig of the white flowers on the Saskatoon bushes at the edge of the raspberry rows.

Come, she said. *Let's go.*

Put your gold on, he said. *All of it. Make it a celebration.*

She did. Two of his cousins drove them south, down the Chuckanut and up the long gravel road on Blanchard Mountain to the overlook where the hang gliders jump off, all of them laughing in the car, Simran in her gold in the back seat with the dabba in her lap.

At the top of the road Raj got out and stretched.

You guys go on back, he said to the cousins. *We'll call you. This part is just for the two of us.* He turned to her. *You carry the prashad. You have to carry it yourself, the whole way, or it doesn't count.*

She carried it. They walked the trail through the woods, two and a half miles, up the gentle back side of the mountain, through the firs and over the creek, and where the creek was high he picked her up and carried her across in his arms, gold and dabba and all, and she laughed and held on.

III. The Dome

Blanchard Mountain · April 2009

Oyster Dome is a knob of rock at the top of the mountain that the trail comes up to from behind, through the trees, on the easy side. On the other side there is no easy way. The rock ends in the air. Below it the mountain falls away a thousand feet and more, cliff and talus and the tops of trees, down to the highway and the railroad and the gray flat water of Samish Bay, and beyond that the islands, Lummi and Orcas and the others, one behind the other into the haze. The sign at the trailhead says to keep back from the edge. It does not say why. Anyone who has stood there knows why.

She stood on the rock in her gold with the dabba in both hands and looked out at all of it.

Here. Let's give it here. Say the ardas.

He said nothing.

Raj? Why aren't you saying anything?

I don't need the prashad, he said. *There wasn't any promise. I made it up to get you up here.*

Then why are we here?

To kill you, he said, *and take your gold, and go.*

The fear went through her so hard that the dabba shook in her hands.

Raj. My gold is yours. I'm yours. Why are you saying this?

She begged him. She said *don't* again and again, and every time he only said, *I'm going to kill you.*

But what do you get by killing me? Take it. Take all of it. The necklace, the bangles, the earrings, take everything and let me live. Think of me as your mother from now on. Or let me be your servant. I'll clean for you. I'll work for you. Just let me live.

If I let you live, he said, *you'll go straight to your father and tell him everything, and he'll have me in Walla Walla by Tuesday. No. I'm going to kill you, and that's all there is. Don't make a lot of noise about it. Take the gold off and put it in a pile and let's get it over with.*

She stood there on the rock and thought, *What a thing. What a thing for a man to do.* And then she thought a thing her grandmother used to say in the kitchen in Lynden, which was that you can't cook your brains and eat them, so you might as well use them before you jump. *All right,* she thought. *All right. I'll find a way.*

Raj, she said. *When they walked you out of that field, I went to my father. My father paid all that money to bring you back. He took you into his family. Since that day I've done everything for you. Do one thing for me today. Let me touch your feet. Let me bow to you the way my mother bows to my father, one last time, before you do it.*

All right, he said. *Go on.*

And he stood on the edge of the rock with the whole of Samish Bay behind him.

She set the dabba down. She walked around him three times, slowly, with him always on her right hand, the way you walk around the Guru, the way she had walked the laavan in November. Then she knelt and touched his feet, the right foot and the left foot, and his right knee and his left knee, and stood up.

This is the last time I'll see you, she said. *You won't see me after this, and I won't see you.* She put her arms around him from the front and held him. Then she went around behind him, as if to hold him from behind too, and he stood easy with his back to her and his face to the bay, a man who has never in his life been afraid of a girl. She put one hand flat on his shoulder and the other flat on the small of his back and pushed.

He went over the edge without a sound. Then there was a sound, a long way down.

She stood alone on the rock. A bald eagle was hanging in the wind just off the edge, at the height of her face, with its wings out, not moving them, the way they do on that mountain when the air comes up the cliff. It had been there the whole time. Afterward she was never sure whether anybody spoke, or whether it was only the wind coming up the face of the mountain. But she heard it plainly, close, in Punjabi, a woman's voice.

It isn't always the man who's clever. A woman is clever too, when it counts. Look at her.

The eagle tipped one wing and slid away down the wind toward the bay.

IV. The House of Questions

Seattle · 2009–2011

SHE SAT DOWN ON THE ROCK AND THOUGHT IT THROUGH, THE way she would learn to think everything through. If she went home, they would ask, *Where is Raj?* If she said, *I pushed him off Oyster Dome,* they would say, *We paid for that boy. We bought him back from Walla Walla with our money, for you, and you killed him.* If she said, *He was going to kill me for my gold,* nobody would believe her. A girl like her. A boy like him. They would not believe her at the gurdwara, and they would not believe her at the sheriff's office in Bellingham.

Then I'm finished with home, she thought.

She took off the gold. The necklace and the earrings and all the bangles, one by one, and the steel kara from her right wrist, which she had worn since she was two. She laid them on the rock beside the dabba

of karah prashad and the five kinds of flowers. Then she walked down the other trail, the steep one, to Chuckanut Drive, and stood at the side of the road until a woman in a pickup stopped. In the restroom of the bus station in Mount Vernon she cut her hair off with a pair of nail scissors, all of it, close to her head, and dropped it in the trash, and got on the bus to Seattle.

The sheriff found Raj at the bottom a week later. Hikers found the gold. The newspaper in Bellingham said a young Lynden man had apparently fallen from Oyster Dome, and that his wife was missing, and that the family asked for privacy. Nobody ever found her, because nobody ever looked very hard, because her father would not let them.

• • •

There was a house on Capitol Hill, a big shabby house with a porch, where eight or nine women lived together and argued. They had a podcast that people listened to in other countries, and a reading group, and a debate night on Thursdays that was standing room only, and they took in girls who had nowhere else to go, and did not ask a lot of questions about where they had come from. Somebody on the bus told her about it. She went and stood on the porch with her cropped hair and said, *Please let me in,* and they let her in.

After a month she asked Dana, who had started the house, what it was all for.

Two ways, said Dana. *Some of us sit. Meditation, mostly; you can learn it here. Some of us argue. We learn every question there is about God and gods and souls and scripture, every objection, every answer to every objection, a thousand of them, and we go out and ask them. Either one gets you free, if you go all the way.*

I can't sit, said Simran. She had tried, the week before. She had closed her eyes and seen the eagle. *I'll learn the questions.*

She learned them. All of them. She learned them the way her father had learned raspberries, all at once and down to the root, and in eighteen months there was nobody in the house who could stand up to her on a Thursday night, and Dana sat her down on the porch.

You're done here, she said. *Go find somebody who can answer you. If you find some ordinary person who beats you, a farmer, a bus driver, whoever, go and work for them. If it's a priest or a preacher or a monk, whatever they are, go and become one.*

And she put a branch of vine maple in Simran's hand, from the tree by the porch, with the leaves just coming out.

V. The Branch

The Northwest · 2011–2012

She called herself the Branch, online, and that was what people called her, and before long a great many people knew the name.

She went from Bellingham to Eugene and out to Spokane and Boise. Before she went into any town she would find the biggest church, or the mosque, or the temple, or the chaplain's office at the college, and set a bucket of sand by the door and stand her branch up in it, and tape a card to the bucket that said, *If you can answer my questions, step on this.* Then she went to find something to eat. Nobody stepped on it. When she came back the branch was always standing, and somebody had always filmed it, and by evening it was online. When a branch dried out, she cut a new one. There is vine maple all over the Northwest.

Some of them argued with her. Ministers, a rabbi in Portland, a Jesuit at Gonzaga who liked her and lost anyway. She asked them her questions in front of everybody, politely, one after another, and they ran out of answers long before she ran out of questions, and the videos went around. After a while nobody argued with her. When people heard the Branch was coming, they found they had somewhere else to be that week. Pastors went to conferences. The doors were locked when she got there.

She was very good at it. She knew she was very good at it. She was twenty-one and she had nothing in the world but a backpack and a thousand questions, and nobody alive could answer her, and some nights in the motel she lay awake and thought that was the same as being free.

VI. The Langar Hall

Kent, Washington · August 2012

In the second week of August she came to the gurdwara in the valley at Kent.

She had stayed away from gurdwaras for three years. She told herself it was not on purpose. But that August a man had walked into a gurdwara in Oak Creek, Wisconsin, on a Sunday morning, while the women were cooking the langar, and killed six people with a pistol, and every gurdwara in America had been on the news since, and she found she could not stay away from this one. She set her bucket of sand by the gate in the chain-link fence, beside the bunches of flowers people had left there for Oak Creek, and stood the vine maple up in it, and taped on her card. Then she went down the street to get coffee.

A crowd of boys from the Sunday Punjabi school gathered around the bucket. They knew who she was. Everybody did. They stood around the branch with their patkas on and their hands in their pockets and dared each other, and nobody touched it.

Baba Kartar Singh came out the side door of the langar hall a little after one, wiping his hands. He had eaten, and washed the big pots, and was going home to sleep. He was seventy-four. He had driven a truck for thirty-one years, Seattle to Chicago and back, Seattle to Los Angeles, every road in the West, until his back gave out, and now he did seva in the langar and on weekday mornings read from the Guru Granth Sahib to whoever came, which was mostly old people, and on Sundays taught the boys their Gurmukhi letters. He had a white beard to his chest and a dark blue turban and he walked slowly.

What's all this? he said.

They told him. The Branch. The questions. The videos. The pastor in Spokane who went to a conference.

Baba Kartar Singh looked at the vine maple for a while.

Go on, he said. *Step on it.*

Baba-ji, we're scared to.

Step on it. I'll answer her questions. Go on.

That was all they needed. They kicked the bucket over and jumped on the branch, all of them at once, yelling, and stamped it flat into the gravel of the parking lot, and kicked the sand everywhere, and somebody filmed that too.

• • •

She came back with her coffee and stopped.

I wasn't going to argue with you, she said to the boys. *I don't argue with children. Why did you do that?*

Baba-ji told us to.

The old man was sitting on the bench by the side door. She went over and stood in front of him.

Baba-ji. Did you tell them to step on my branch?

Yes, beti.

Then you answer my questions.

All right. Come back tonight.

By evening it was everywhere. Every Punjabi phone from Surrey to Yuba City had the video of the boys jumping on the branch, and by eight o'clock the langar hall was full, families from Kent and Renton and Auburn and Federal Way, people who had driven down from the farms on the Guide, a news van in the parking lot, everybody sitting on the long strips of carpet on the floor with their heads covered and paper plates of dal and roti in front of them, and the sevadars going up and down the rows with buckets. Baba Kartar Singh sat on the floor at the front of the hall in a clean white kurta, with nothing in his hands. She sat facing him. Somebody gave her a scarf for her cropped hair, and she put it on without thinking.

I want to ask you some questions, she said.

Ask, beti.

She asked him everything. She asked him the thousand questions. If there was one God, why were there so many religions, and why did all of them say theirs was right? If God was good, why Oak Creek? Why did the women cook the langar and the men read the Granth, if the Gurus said the women were not less? If everything was God's will, then who did the

wrong, the man with the pistol or God? Where was the soul before it was born? What did a child have to do with karma? Why should anybody believe a book that men had written down?

He answered every one of them. He did not hurry. He answered in plain Punjabi and plain English, the way he would tell a man where to get off the interstate, and sometimes he answered with a line from the Gurus and sometimes with something he had seen in a truck stop in Wyoming. Every answer was the right one. The people in the hall could feel it, one after another, the way you feel a truck shift into the right gear. Nobody had ever seen her stopped before.

At ten o'clock she ran out.

Is that all, beti?

That's all of them.

You asked me a lot of questions. Can I ask you just one?

Ask.

What is one?

She almost laughed. Every child in the hall knew. It was the first word of the Guru Granth Sahib, the first thing her grandmother had taught her to say, before her own name. It was written in gold over the door.

> *There is but one God whose name is true, the Creator, devoid of fear and enmity, immortal, unborn, self-existent; by the favour of the Guru.*
>
> *— Japji, the opening lines*

Ik Oankar, she said. *One. Every kid in this room can tell you that.*

I didn't ask you what they can say. I asked you what one is.

She opened her mouth to answer, and there was nothing in it. She knew the words. She had known them all her life. She did not know the thing. She looked at him, and the hall was so quiet she could hear the sevadars setting the buckets down.

I don't know, she said. *Tell me.*

That one is the Guru's question, beti. Not mine.

Then tell me the Guru's answer.

Become what I am, said Baba Kartar Singh, *and I'll tell you.*

What are you?

A Sikh, he said. *A learner. That's all the word means.*

She sat on the carpet in the borrowed scarf with the whole hall looking at her, and the news van outside, and the trampled branch out in the parking lot under the lights, and she said, *Then make me one.*

VII. Curly

Kent · 2013

Baba Kartar Singh did not make her anything. He sent her to the women. She stayed that winter with a widow from the sangat who had a room over her garage, and she worked in the langar kitchen, and she did not argue with anyone. At Vaisakhi in April, with the other initiates, she took amrit from the Panj Pyare in the gurdwara at Kent, and put on the five things, and a new steel kara on her right wrist, and kept her hair from that day uncut.

It came in curly. It had been straight all her life, down to her waist, and she had cut it off in a bus station in Mount Vernon, and now it came back in tight curls that would not stay under her chunni, and the boys from the Punjabi school, who had jumped on her branch, called her Ghungrali Bibi, Curly Bibi, and then everybody did.

Some time in that first spring, nobody could ever say exactly when, the thing happened to her that she had come for. She did not talk about it. People who had known the Branch did not recognize her. She rolled roti in the langar kitchen for three hundred people on a Sunday and did not say a word all morning, and the women who worked beside her said later that it was like standing next to a window with the sun coming in.

• • •

The men who sat on the bench by the side door after langar could not let it alone. One Sunday in May they were at it again while Baba Kartar Singh sat at the end of the bench with his eyes closed.

She heard one evening of it. One. Baba-ji answered her questions and asked her one, and that was the end of it. My cousin's been coming here forty years and he's still the same man.

And before that, you know what she did, everybody knows. That boy on the mountain. She beat him, a girl of eighteen. Whatever you want to call it, she beat him.

Baba Kartar Singh opened his eyes.

Don't count it, he said. *Don't measure it by how much. That girl came in here with a thousand questions in her and all of them empty, and every one of them was a fight, and she won every fight. It doesn't matter. One word with something in it is worth more than all of that. Guru Nanak said it.*

> *A man may load carts with books; he may load men with books to take with him;*
>
> *Books may be put on boats; pits may be filled with them.*
>
> *A man may read books for months; he may read them for years;*
>
> *He may read them for life; he may read them while he hath breath—*
>
> *Nanak, only one word, God's name, would be of account; all else would be the senseless discussion of pride.*
>
> *— Asa ki War, slok of Guru Nanak*

And the boy on the mountain, he said. *Forget the boy on the mountain. You can beat a thousand men, beat them a thousand times, on a mountain or in a debate or in a war, and you haven't won anything. The one you have to beat is yourself. Beat that one and you've won it all. That's the only fight. She's won it.*

> *Make association with men thine Ai Panth, and the conquest of thy heart the conquest of the world.*
>
> *— Japji 28*

The Ai Panth were the yogis, he said. *The proudest order there was. Make everybody you meet your order, the Guru says, and beat your own heart. That's the whole world beaten.*

The men on the bench were quiet. One of them, Sohan Singh Dhillon's nephew, who had driven down from Lynden for Sunday, looked at the kitchen door a long time.

Inside, Ghungrali Bibi was at the big griddle with flour to her elbows, turning roti with her bare fingers the way the old women do, one after another, hundreds of them, each one rising and filling with steam and going onto the pile, and her curls had come out from under her chunni again, and she did not stop to push them back.

Background

The verses

> *Though a man recite a hundred Gathas made up of senseless words, one word of the law is better, which if a man hears, he becomes quiet.*
>
> Dhammapada 102, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If one man conquer in battle a thousand times thousand men, and if another conquer himself, he is the greatest of conquerors.*
>
> Dhammapada 103, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich merchant's daughter of Rājagaha, kept on the top floor of her father's house, sees a young robber being whipped through the streets to his execution and refuses to eat until she has him. Her father bribes the officer to free him and execute another man in his place. The robber marries her, wants her jewels, and pretends he owes an offering to the deity of Robbers' Cliff. At the top he tells her he means to kill her. She asks to honor him one last time, walks around him three times, embraces him and pushes him over. Unable to go home, she joins a band of women wanderers, masters a thousand philosophical views, and travels from town to town planting a rose-apple branch at the gates and challenging anyone who can answer her to trample it. At Sāvatthī the elder Sāriputta has some boys trample it. He answers all her questions, then asks her one, "What is one?" She cannot answer it, asks to be ordained, takes the name Kuṇḍalakesī ("curly hair") and soon becomes an arahant. Read the full commentary story, or about Kuṇḍalakesī and the Tamil epic that retold her story.

Lynden and Kent, Washington

Sikhs in western Washington, 1907-2012

In September 1907 a mob of about five hundred men drove the Sikh mill workers out of Bellingham. Sikhs did not come back to Whatcom County in numbers for most of a century. When they did, beginning in the 1980s, they came mostly as farmers who had first prospered across the border in British Columbia. Today nearly a hundred Sikh farmers work some five thousand acres of berries there, in a county that grows about two-thirds of the raspberries in the United States (KUOW). In 1993 Washington voters approved Initiative 593, the first true three-strikes law in the country. On August 5, 2012, a white supremacist killed six worshippers at the Sikh Temple of Wisconsin in Oak Creek while the langar was being prepared.

Oyster Dome is a rock promontory on Blanchard Mountain above Samish Bay. The trail approaches it through the forest from the Samish Overlook, a hang-gliding launch, and ends at an unfenced edge with an unforgiving drop. The scripture in the story is from the Guru Granth Sahib in Max Arthur Macauliffe's translation, *The Sikh Religion*, volume 1 (1909), which renders the opening words, Ik Oankar, as "There is but one God." In Sikh weddings the couple walks four times around the Guru Granth Sahib, and at initiation, amrit, the five Ks include kesh, uncut hair. The word *Sikh* means a learner or disciple. Everyone in the story is fictional.

After the story of Kuṇḍalakesī from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 102 and 103). The original. Scripture from the Guru Granth Sahib, tr. Max Arthur Macauliffe, *The Sikh Religion* (1909). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.4

Watering Off

Fight manfully onward,
Dark passions subdue.
— H. R. Palmer, "Yield Not to Temptation" (1868)

Now this is the way I heard it, on the backside at the Downs.

I. The Backside

Churchill Downs, Louisville · April 1937

In January the Ohio had come up out of its banks and five miles across the city, and into February it stood six feet deep on the racetrack, brown and still, with the tops of the rails showing like a fence in a pond. When it went down it left the mud. The men spent March raking it off the strip and hauling it away in wagons and putting down new dirt, and by the middle of April there was fresh paint on everything, and the Derby horses were coming in on the train, and people uptown were saying the Downs looked better than before.

The backside smelled the way it always did, of liniment and wet straw and coffee from the track kitchen and the manure pile behind every barn. Before light the grooms came out of the tack rooms, where most of them slept on cots between the saddles, and the exercise boys came up from Smoketown in the dark, and the roosters some of the stables kept went off one after another down the line. By six the horses were going out to the track in the fog, and the clockers stood at the rail with their stopwatches, and the men who bet for a living stood near the clockers.

Isom Tandy walked hots for Mr. Dade Collier's stable in Barn 22. He was fifty-six years old and stood about five feet two, and he still weighed what he had weighed at nineteen. When a horse came back blowing from

a work or a race, steaming, with its veins up under the skin, Isom took the shank and walked it around the shed row under the overhang, around and around, for most of an hour, until its breathing came down and its coat was dry and it was a horse again and not a fire. A bucket hung at the corner of the row. Each time around he let the horse put its nose in, and let it have three swallows, and then he lifted its head out of the water. A hot horse will drink a bucket dry and founder on it. He never let one.

The exercise boys called him Mister Isom. The white men called him Isom. He did not bet, and he did not give tips, though people were always asking him, because it was known on the backside that he could watch a horse cool out and tell you whether it had another race in it.

He had ridden once. He had been a jockey from the time he was twelve, at Latonia across the river and at the old Oakley track in Cincinnati and in the East, and he had won a great deal, in the years when most of the boys who rode in Kentucky were colored boys. Then, in the years after nineteen hundred, the colored boys stopped getting mounts. White riders put them into the rail and nobody fined them for it. Owners who had hired them stopped hiring them. A few went to Europe. Most went to the barns, if they stayed at all. Isom stayed. He rubbed horses for twenty years, and when his back got too bad for the stall work he walked them, and he had been walking them ever since.

He did not talk about any of that. The boys had it from their fathers.

II. The Question

Barn 22 · a morning in the last week of April

Mr. Carroll Ashby came down the shed row at about seven, with the fog still lying on the infield and the sun just coming red through it. He was a white man of forty or so in a camel-hair coat, with field glasses on a strap around his neck and the *Racing Form* folded lengthwise in his pocket. He lived at the Seelbach in the season and at Hialeah in the winter, and he was known on every backside from Saratoga to New Orleans as a man who made his living at the windows and had been making it for twenty years.

Isom had a gray two-year-old on the shank, just back from a bad work, blowing hard. Lafayette Moss, who was sixteen and galloped horses for Mr. Collier, sat on an upturned bucket by the tack room door with a bridle across his knees, mending a rein.

Mr. Ashby fell in beside Isom and walked with him.

Morning, Isom.

Morning, Mr. Ashby.

They tell me you know horses. They tell me you can look at one cooling out and say if he'll run back.

Isom walked. The gray put its nose down to the bucket at the corner and took three swallows, and Isom lifted its head and walked on.

Now I've been wondering something, Mr. Ashby said. *A man who knows winners. Does he know losers too? Or does he just know the one side?*

I know both, said Isom.

All right. Tell me about losing, then.

They went around the end of the row, past Lafayette on his bucket, and Isom said it walking, the way he said everything, without looking around.

Lying down when the sun's up. A horse still lying down in his stall at daylight is a sick horse, and a man is the same. That's one.

Lazy. That's two.

Mean. A mean horse runs his race in the stall, kicking the boards, and hasn't got anything left at the head of the stretch. That's three.

Drinking. Not a night of it. A long time of it. That's four.

Going down a long road by yourself. That's five.

Another man's wife. That's six.

The gray put its nose in the bucket. Three swallows. Isom lifted its head.

You go after any of those, Mr. Ashby, he said, *you're going to lose. You don't need me for that.*

Mr. Ashby laughed out loud, and a horse in a stall down the row put its head out to look at him.

Isom, that's a whole sermon. You ought to have a congregation. You're right, though. You know both sides of it.

There isn't anybody on this ground, Isom said, *knows losing the way I know it.*

He did not say it hard. He said it the way he would say what a horse weighed. Lafayette, on his bucket, stopped mending the rein. Mr. Ashby looked at the old man for a moment as if he were going to ask something, and then he did not ask it.

III. Often Cast Down

Barn 22 · the same morning

They went around again. The sun was clear of the fog now and the shed row was striped with it, light and shadow, light and shadow, and the gray walked through the stripes with its head lower than before.

Isom looked at the field glasses and the folded *Form,* and at the camel-hair coat, which was a good coat and had been mended once at the cuff, very well, by somebody who knew how.

How do you make your living, Mr. Ashby?

You know how I make it. I bet.

Who wins?

Some days me, Mr. Ashby said. *Some days the windows.*

Isom let the gray drink, and lifted its head, and walked on.

Beating the other man, he said, *that's a little thing. There isn't anything in it. You beat the windows Tuesday and the windows beat you Saturday. I won a race at Latonia once by a nose, and the man I beat went out and beat me the next day by two lengths, and the next week neither one of us had a mount. That kind of winning comes back on you. It always comes back.*

But a man who gets the better of what's in himself, he said, *the mean, and the lazy, and the bottle, and all of it. A man who beats that, and keeps on beating it every morning, that one stays won. Nobody can take it back off him. Not the stewards up in the stand. Not the Jockey Club in New York. Not the riders that put you into the rail. Not the devil. The river came up six feet over this track this winter, and it couldn't take that back off a man.*

He walked on a while. Then, because Mr. Ashby was still walking beside him and seemed to be waiting, he said the words of a song the children sang at his church on Walnut Street, flat, not singing it, in time with the gray's feet.

To him that o'ercometh,
God giveth a crown,
Through faith we shall conquer,
Tho' often cast down;
He who is our Saviour,
Our strength will renew.
Look ever to Jesus,
He'll carry you through.

— H. R. Palmer, "Yield Not to Temptation," stanza 3

Mr. Ashby did not say anything to that. At the end of the row he stopped, and took the *Form* out of his pocket and looked at it, and put it back. He touched his hat brim to Isom, which he had never done before, and went back up toward the rail where the clockers were, with the sun on the back of his coat. Whether he bet that afternoon, nobody on the backside knew. Lafayette heard later that he had gone to Hialeah the next winter as usual. People do what they do.

• • •

But Lafayette Moss had been carrying a two-dollar ticket in his shirt pocket for three days, on a horse that had run fifth, because he could not make himself throw it away. He took it out now and looked at it, and tore it in half, and in half again, and let the pieces go in the straw. Then he put the bridle down and got up off his bucket.

Let me have him a while, Mister Isom.

Isom gave him the shank. The gray was nearly cool. Its coat had dried in rough patches along the neck where the sweat had been, and its breath came slow. They went around once, the boy and the horse, through the stripes of sun, and Isom stood by the tack room door and watched them.

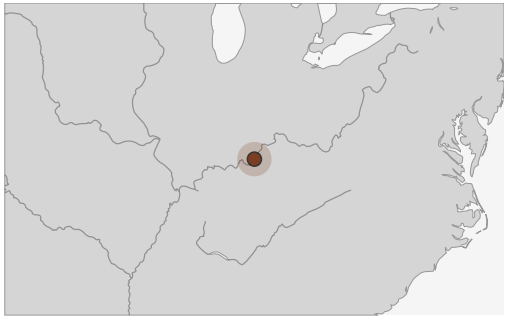
At the corner the gray put its nose down into the bucket and drank, one swallow, two, three, and Lafayette took hold of the halter and lifted its head out of the water, and the gray let him, and the water ran off its chin in a string and fell back into the bucket, and they walked on.

Background

The verses

> *One's own self conquered is better than all other people; not even a god, a Gandharva, not Mara with Brahman could change into defeat the victory of a man who has vanquished himself, and always lives under restraint.*
>
> Dhammapada 104–105, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a brahmin wonders whether the Buddha knows only what brings gain, or what brings loss as well, and goes to Jetavana to ask him. The Buddha says he knows both and names six roads to loss: sleeping after sunrise, idleness, ferocity, long drunkenness, going on a long journey alone, and other men's wives. The brahmin praises him as a teacher and leader of a following, and the Buddha answers that no one knows loss as well as he does. Then the Buddha asks the brahmin how he lives. By gambling, he says; sometimes he wins and sometimes the other man does. The Buddha tells him that victory over another is a small thing, and that the victory of one who conquers himself is one that no god or demon can turn into defeat. Read the full commentary story.



Louisville, Kentucky

The backside at Churchill Downs, 1937

Black horsemen built American racing. Thirteen of the fifteen riders in the first Kentucky Derby, in 1875, were Black, and Black jockeys won fifteen of the first

twenty-eight Derbies, among them Isaac Murphy, who won three. Around the turn of the century they were driven out of the saddle by racism, by violence from white riders that went unpunished, and by the shrinking of racing under anti-gambling laws. Jimmy Winkfield, the last Black jockey to win the Derby, in 1902, left to ride in Russia and Europe. After Henry King rode in 1921, no Black jockey rode in the Derby again until 2000. Many Black horsemen stayed on as grooms, trainers and hot walkers; the Smithsonian tells the story.

In January 1937 the Ohio River flood put about seventy percent of Louisville under water and drove some 175,000 people from their homes. By early February the track at Churchill Downs, more than five miles from the river, lay under about six feet of water; the crew rebuilt the strip, and the Derby was run on schedule on May 8 (the Kentucky Derby Museum has the story). After a race or a workout a hot walker leads a horse until it has cooled, and the old practice, still remembered on the backstretch, was to let a hot horse have only a few swallows of water at a time.

After the story of the brahmin who asked about loss, from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 104–105). The original. Hymn text by H. R. Palmer (1868), as printed in *Christ in Song* (1908). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.5

Each Halting Place

To soothe by a kindness one heart has more grace,
Than a thousand prostrations at each halting place.
— Sa'di, Bustan II, tr. G. S. Davie

Chunīn shunīdam, in the kabob houses on Fremont Boulevard.

I. The Envelope

Fremont, California · the first Friday of February 2026

Haji Wahid sold floors. He had come to Fremont in 1984 with a wife, a sister, two rugs and a cousin's telephone number. He sold the two rugs, and then other men's rugs, and when the people who bought rugs began to want laminate he learned laminate. Now there was a showroom on Fremont Boulevard with forty feet of sample racks, a warehouse in Union City, three vans, and his name on the pens.

On the first Friday of every month, after the prayer, he sat down at the desk in the back of the showroom and counted ten hundred-dollar bills into an envelope. He had done it since the spring of 2004. He wrote the month on the flap in pencil and walked the envelope two doors down to the travel agency, where the man at the rear counter wrote a line in a book and made a telephone call, and by Sunday a cousin of the mullah in his father's village above Charikar had the money in his hand. In twenty-two years the envelope had built a mosque of fired brick with a blue door. Then it had built a wall around the mosque, a well, a room for the boys to learn in, a loudspeaker, and last year four solar panels. A stonecutter had put his father's name over the door. Wahid kept a photograph of it under the glass of the desk. He had never seen it any other way.

His sister's son came in while he was licking the flap.

Yusuf was forty-three. He had been a clever boy. At twenty-four he had gone back over there to interpret for the Americans, for more money than Wahid cleared in those years, and he had come home at thirty with the money gone nobody knew where and a habit of sitting with his back to a wall. He had not married. He lived in an apartment in Sacramento and interpreted by the hour at the immigration court, Dari and Pashto. What he did with the rest of his time his mother had told Wahid on the telephone the night before, crying. Every Sunday since December he drove to a prison in the desert, eleven hours there and back, to see an old man who was no relation.

Sit, Wahid said. *Your mother says you are killing yourself on the highway. For what? What good does it do?*

Yusuf sat. He looked at the envelope.

Māmā, he said. *Do you do any good? One thing?*

It was not how a man spoke to his mother's brother. But Wahid had been waiting twenty-two years for somebody to ask.

This, he said, and put his hand flat on it. *A thousand dollars. Every month since you were in college.*

Who gets it?

The mullah. For the mosque, for the boys' teacher, for whatever the mosque needs.

And what do you get?

Wahid was not ashamed of the answer. *A house. There. Whoever builds a house for God, God builds a house for him in the Garden.*

Who told you that?

Mullah Sahib. It is hadith, bachem. Ask anybody.

I know it is hadith. I am asking who has been up that road to look. You have not been, and Mullah Sahib has not been. He knows the road as far as the counter at the travel agency. Yusuf said it without heat, the way he would give a client the date of a hearing. *I know one man who knows the rest of it. He is where I go on Sundays. Come with me and I will ask him for you.*

Wahid looked at his father's blue door under the glass. Then he looked at his sister's son, briefly, the way he had looked at him for years, as a man glances at a bill he means to dispute.

What time, he said.

II. The Road

Interstate 5 · Sunday, before light

They left at four in one of the vans, because Wahid would not ride eleven hours in a Corolla. Yusuf's mother came out to the driveway in her coat with a pot of qabuli wrapped in two bath towels. She set it in the back among the sample boards and stood there until they turned the corner.

Over the Altamont and down into the valley the fog lay on the road as if it had been poured. Yusuf drove at fifty with the trucks. At the Westley rest area Wahid got out, washed at the tap with the cold running into his sleeves, took a carpet sample from the van, a two-foot square of gray Saxony with the price on the back, and prayed the dawn prayer on it beside the picnic tables. Yusuf prayed behind him on the concrete.

After that there was light, and Yusuf talked.

The teacher's name was Abdul Latif, and in Herat they called him Ustad Latif. He had taught Persian literature to boys for thirty-one years in a government high school. When the schools for girls were shut he taught girls, Sa'di and Hafez and their own grammar, in his guest room with the curtain drawn, until a neighbor warned him. He was sixty-seven. He went out through Iran. Brazil was giving visas then, so he flew to São Paulo and slept three weeks in the airport under a blanket hung over a row of chairs, and then he walked north with people a third his age, through the jungle between Colombia and Panama and on through Mexico. In the fall of 2023 he asked for asylum at the fence south of San Diego. They let him go on to a former student in Sacramento with a monitor on his ankle and a date to check in.

In Sacramento he did what he had always done. On Friday nights, in an apartment off Fulton Avenue, he read the Bustan with whoever came: taxi men, a pharmacist, two widows, Yusuf. He read a story and then asked each person what was in it. He did not correct anybody. He waited, and the next person said something better.

They called him at six in the morning on the first of December, Yusuf said. *Him and the others. Come to the federal building now. He put on his good coat. The people who stand outside with clipboards counted six that day. The handcuffs went on in the doorway.*

What did he do?

They have not said.

At Kettleman City Wahid bought two coffees and would not let Yusuf pay. The road ran on between almond orchards coming into bloom, then east, then up through Tehachapi among the white windmills, hundreds of them turning on the ridges, and down the far side into a brown country without trees. California City had streets. Wahid had laid floors in three counties, and he noticed the streets before anything else. They were paved and had their names on posts, and they ran off square to the horizon through the creosote with not one house on them.

Somebody was going to build a city, Yusuf said. *In the fifties. They did the streets first.*

III. The Glass

California City · eleven o'clock

IT HAD BEEN A PRISON, AND IT WAS ONE. THERE WERE THREE gates that slid. A woman behind a window took their licenses, and they waited in a room with six chairs. Then a guard gave each of them a badge and pressed a stamp on the back of each right hand that left no mark at all. They put keys, belts and Wahid's prayer beads in a gray bin and took off their shoes.

The visiting room was large and nearly empty, with two vending machines at the far end. Along one side ran a row of booths with glass in them, and at each booth a chair and a telephone on the wall. At the first one a woman was holding a baby up to the glass.

They brought him in on the other side. Wahid had expected a holy beggar, or else a professor. He saw a small man in the loose clothes they give them, with a clipped white beard and heavy glasses mended at the hinge, who looked at Yusuf first and laughed with pleasure, and then

looked at Wahid and put his hand on his heart. There was one telephone. Yusuf took it.

Ustad, this is my mother's brother, Haji Abdul Wahid of Fremont. He is building a mosque in Parwan. He has sent a thousand dollars every month for twenty-two years, and he hopes for a house in the Garden. I told him he does not know the road there and his mullah does not. Tell him.

He held the receiver out, and Wahid took it. It was warm.

Haji Sahib, said the voice in his ear, in the Persian of Herat. *Is it as he says?*

It is, Ustad-jan.

The old man nodded. He was in no hurry, though somewhere a clock was running on both of them.

A mosque is a good thing. I have prayed in a hundred that men like you built, and I asked a blessing on every builder. Send your thousand. Send it a hundred years. His eyes moved to Yusuf, who stood with his arms folded. *Now look there. That one has come to me ten Sundays. I am not his father. He drives through the night to hold this telephone, and he asks me who in my unit has no lawyer, and he carries the names out in his head, because they do not let him bring a pen. If one time you looked at him with a clear heart, Haji Sahib, the way you looked at me when I came through that door, for as long as it takes to say bismillah, it would weigh more than the hundred years. Or if you put one spoon of rice on his plate with your own hand. I do not say it to shame you. You asked for the road.*

Then he said two lines into the mouthpiece, quietly, as a man gives a street address. *Ba ehsānē āsūda kardan dilē, beh az alf rak'at ba har manzilē.*

Do not think that because you have worshipped so fine,
You have carried a gift to this Presence Divine!
To soothe by a kindness one heart has more grace,
Than a thousand prostrations at each halting place.

— Sa'di, Bustan II, tr. G. S. Davie

Wahid had known the lines since he was nine. A master in Charikar had put them into forty boys with a mulberry switch. He had said them himself, at funerals, to men richer than he was.

He turned his head. It was a small thing to do. Yusuf's lips were moving a little. He was going over the names. There was gray in his beard that Wahid had never taken in, and his collar was frayed and very clean, and he stood in that room the way the old man sat in it, as if nothing in it could be taken from him.

Wahid looked for as long as it takes to say it. He had pulled up a great deal of bad carpet in his life, and now and then there was oak under it, tight and dry, laid by somebody who knew how. That was the nearest he could come to it afterward.

Ustad, he said into the telephone, and could not go on. The old man raised one hand a few inches off the counter, as you do for a student who need not finish the sentence.

Let me put money in your account, Wahid said, when he could. *Whatever they allow.*

Twenty dollars. There is a boy from Guinea in my unit whose people do not know where he is. It will buy him soup and a call.

The guard said time.

IV. The Plate

The parking lot · noon

On the way out a guard passed a violet lamp over the backs of their hands, and the stamp that had not been there showed for a second, a small green wheel. Then they were through the three gates with their shoes on.

The wind was blowing. Yusuf opened the back of the van and unwrapped the pot, which was still warm in the middle. He found the two plates his mother had put in, and the spoon.

Wahid took the spoon out of his hand.

He was the elder. In sixty-six years nobody younger had been served in front of him. He dug down to where the rice was hot and lifted a spoonful

with the carrots and raisins on it and a piece of the lamb, and put it on his nephew's plate. Then he put another.

Eat, he said. *You have to drive.*

Yusuf looked at the plate and then at him. He ate standing up, with the wind lifting a corner of the towel, and Wahid, who had not yet taken any for himself, watched him.

• • •

On the first Friday of March he counted ten bills into the envelope and wrote the month on the flap, as before. A village is not hurt by a well.

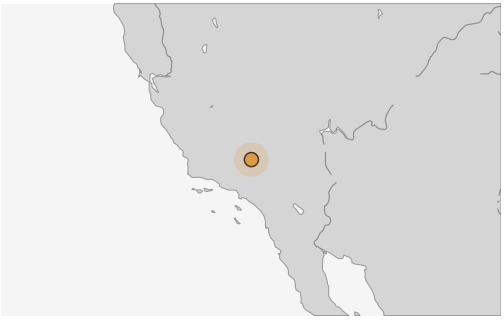
On the Sunday after that the van went south at four with the sample boards out and the seats bolted back in, nine people from the apartment off Fulton Avenue, and a pot the size of a truck tire. At Westley he passed out the carpet squares, gray Saxony, one to a person, and they stood in a row beside the picnic tables in the fog and put their foreheads down on them.

Background

The verse

> *If a man for a hundred years sacrifice month after month with a thousand, and if he but for one moment pay homage to a man whose soul is grounded (in true knowledge), better is that homage than sacrifice for a hundred years.*
>
> Dhammapada 106, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Sāriputta visits his uncle, a Brahmin, and asks him whether he ever does a single good deed. The uncle answers that month after month he gives a thousand coins to the naked ascetics, because his teachers have told him this is the way to the world of Brahmā. Sāriputta says that neither he nor his teachers know the way there, and takes him to the Buddha. The Buddha tells him that a hundred years of such giving would bear less fruit than a single moment of looking at his disciple with a believing heart, or one spoonful of boiled rice put in his bowl. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.



Fremont and California City, California

Fremont and California City, 2026

Afghan families began arriving in the East Bay as refugees after the Soviet invasion of 1979, and Fremont came to hold the best-known Afghan American community in the country; Sacramento County now has the largest. After the Taliban took Kabul in August 2021, Brazil issued humanitarian visas to several thousand Afghans, and some of them went on north overland, through the Darién Gap and Mexico, to ask for asylum at the United States border. Hundreds camped for weeks in the São Paulo airport on the way. In the days after an Afghan man shot two National Guard soldiers in Washington in November 2025, immigration lawyers reported a wave of arrests of Afghans, most of them in Northern California. In Sacramento, men who had asked for asylum at the border were telephoned at six in the morning on December 1, told to report to the federal building at once, and handcuffed as they came in; volunteers counted six arrests that day. The Associated Press, which reported this, could not confirm the reasons given in each case.

California City was laid out in the Mojave Desert in 1958 for 400,000 people who never came, and it is still a grid of paved streets with few houses, the third-largest city in California by area. Its private prison, built in 1999, reopened in late August 2025 as an immigration detention center with room for 2,560 people. By January 2026 it held more than 1,400 and was the largest in the state. Visitors there have described the three sliding gates, the invisible hand stamp, and visits through glass by wall telephone. Haji Wahid, Yusuf and Ustad Latif are invented. The lines the Ustad recites are from the second chapter of the Bustan of Sa'di of Shiraz (1257), in G. S. Davie's verse translation of 1882, where an angel says them to a pilgrim who is proud of praying at every step of the road to Mecca.

After the story of the elder Sāriputta's uncle from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 106). The original. Verse from Sa'di's Bustan in G. S. Davie's translation, *The Garden of Fragrance* (1882). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.6

The Ring Seal

The candle alone shines by itself, and for itself, or for those who have arranged the materials.
— Michael Faraday, The Chemical History of a Candle, Lecture I

Tak słyszałem, at the tables in Polish Town.

I. The Source

Upton, Long Island · September 1965

Every morning at eight Gene Mroz pressed a black button in a concrete hut in the pine woods, and a hundred yards off a canister of cesium went down a pipe into the ground. The red light over the gate went out and a green one came on. For four hours after that, people could go in.

At noon he counted them out against the clipboard, counted the film badges back onto their board, walked the fence, locked the gate, and pressed the other button. The canister rose to the top of its pole and stayed there twenty hours. It stayed through the afternoon and the night, in rain, on Christmas, and it shone on the trees with a light nobody could see. It had done that every day since the twenty-second of November, 1961.

You could see what the light had done. From the gate you walked in through ordinary Long Island woods, pitch pine and oak with huckleberry underneath. After a while the pines were dead and only the oaks had leaves, and the white oaks there were sticky with aphids, more aphids than anybody had ever counted on a tree. Farther in, the oaks were dead too. They stood gray, with the bark coming off in plates, and noth-

ing was green above the knee but blueberry and huckleberry. Then the bushes stopped at a ring of sedge as fine as hair, like a lawn nobody had planted. Inside the sedge, around the pole, there was sand, gray sticks and a little moss. The pilots out of Westhampton said that from the air it looked like a target.

Gene was twenty-two. He had grown potatoes with his father outside Riverhead until he was eighteen, and gone to Cornell on the State's money, and come home in June with a degree in botany. His mother's brother worked at the Laboratory and had heard that the forest people wanted a technician who knew plants and did not mind mosquitoes. So Gene ran the source. He read the dosimeters on their stakes. He emptied the litter baskets, bagged the leaves, dried them and weighed them. On the first Monday of each month, outside the fence where the woods were whole, the crew took down one tree, a pine or an oak, and Gene carried it out in pieces and weighed every piece, needles and twigs and wood, to the tenth of a gram.

He had a white coat with his name over the pocket. He ate his lunch at a table with men who had doctorates. He had never been so happy in his life.

II. Sunday

Polish Town, Riverhead · the same month

After the ten o'clock at St. Isidore's they ate at his grandmother's on Pulaski Street, eleven at the table. His Uncle Stash sat at the corner by the stove, where he had sat since before Gene was born.

Stash Kozakiewicz had left school at fifteen for the potatoes. In 1942 the Army swore him in at Camp Upton, on the same sand the Laboratory stood on now. His own father had been a recruit there in 1918, and used to tell about a first sergeant from the coal country who said every man's name right the first time, Kozakiewicz included. When Stash came home from Italy he went back out to Upton and asked for work, and they gave him a broom. That was 1948. He was in the glass shop now. At the table it

was understood that Gene had gone further in three months than Stash had in seventeen years, and Stash had never said a word against it.

He waited until the women were clearing.

Genek. You do any good out there? One thing?

Sure I do.

What?

First of the month we take a tree. And every day I put the source down in the morning and send it back up at noon.

What for?

Gene had not said it aloud before, and he was pleased with how it came out. *That's how you get to be one of them, Uncle. You keep the numbers clean. They say a plot like that ought to run a hundred years, and whoever stays with it will know what a forest is. You do it right long enough and it makes you into something.*

Who told you that?

Everybody up there. My professors.

Stash turned his coffee cup a quarter turn on the saucer, and then another quarter.

They're smart men, he said. *I blow their glass. But how a man gets made into something, they don't know that, and you don't. They got that way and they couldn't tell you how. I know one that can. You got four hours tomorrow with that fire of yours in the ground. Come over to the shop at ten.*

III. The Glass Shop

Upton · Monday, ten o'clock

THE SHOP WAS A LONG ROOM WITH NORTH WINDOWS, AND GAS and oxygen piped along the benches. Glass tubing stood in racks by size, like organ pipes. Mr. Greiner sat at the first bench. He came from Lauscha, in the Thuringian forest, where his father and his grandfather had blown glass. He had come to New York in 1926 and to the Laboratory in its first year, and nearly everything on the site that held a vacuum had been through his hands or through Stash's. He was sixty-three, a small man in a gray shop coat buttoned to the neck, with rose-colored spec-

TACLES PUSHED UP ON HIS FOREHEAD. ON THE BENCH IN FRONT of him a burner made a blue cone the length of a finger.

Stash told him about it in four sentences. Mr. Greiner listened and looked at Gene.

It is so? As he says?

Yes, sir.

So. He shut the oxygen, and the flame went soft and yellow. He shut the gas. *I know your fire in the woods. It is a strong thing. You may send it up and take it down a hundred years. In a hundred years it will be a tenth so strong, and you will be dead, and it will not have made anything of you. It does not know you are there. Better you sit one minute and look at a man who is already made, and look at him the way you look at your doctors. One minute. It would do more.*

What man?

You have eaten Sunday dinner with him since you had teeth.

He opened the drawer under the bench and took out a small brown book with the spine gone. He had bought it on Fourth Avenue in 1927 to learn English from, he said, because he already knew what it said. He had won the same lectures in German as a school prize in Lauscha when he was twelve. He found the place without looking for it.

> *You have the glittering beauty of gold and silver, and the still higher lustre of jewels, like the ruby and diamond; but none of these rival the brilliancy and beauty of flame. What diamond can shine like flame? It owes its lustre at night-time to the very flame shining upon it. The flame shines in darkness, but the light which the diamond has is as nothing until the flame shine upon it, when it is brilliant again. The candle alone shines by itself, and for itself, or for those who have arranged the materials.*
>
> *— Michael Faraday, The Chemical History of a Candle, Lecture I*

You are the diamond, Mr. Greiner said. *It is no shame. Everybody is, at twenty-two. You stand next to a strong thing and you think the shine is yours. Stanislaus. Make him a ring seal.*

Stash sat down at the second bench and pulled his own spectacles down. He took two lengths of tubing from the rack, one that would go inside the other. He lit the gas and fed it oxygen until the flame roared and drew down to a point.

Then he put the glass in. He held a piece in each hand, the left hand under and the right hand over, and both hands turned. They turned at the same speed and they did not stop. The glass went soft and orange, and the flame above it flared yellow. He took it out and breathed into the rubber hose he held in his teeth, and put it back. There was nothing on his face.

Gene had watched this man eat for twenty-two years. The hands were his grandmother's hands, thick in the fingers and cracked at the knuckles from the potato fields, and they moved like water going around a stone. Somewhere in the minute he stopped thinking about what he would say afterward. He forgot that he had a coat with his name on it. When the glass came out of the fire for the last time, one tube stood inside the other, joined by a ring of glass with no line in it anywhere, and it went from orange to clear while he looked.

Stash set it in the rack and pushed his spectacles up.

Seventeen years, Mr. Greiner said. *The first year I gave him a glass rod to turn in his fingers. No fire. He turned it at the supper table, I think.*

He turns his cup, Gene said.

So. You have seen something.

At a quarter to twelve Gene walked back through the woods. He counted the people out and counted the badges and locked the gate, and sent the source up. Then he stood at the fence a while under the red light. He had taken the pencil off the clipboard, and he was turning it in his fingers, the left hand under and the right hand over.

IV. The Candle

Upton · the week before Christmas

Every December Mr. Greiner gave a lecture for the children of the Laboratory. Nobody had asked him to, and nobody paid him

FOR IT. HE DID THE WHOLE OF FARADAY IN AN HOUR AND A half, with one candle, a bell jar, a balance, and a flask of lime-water that turned to milk when he breathed into it through a tube. Stash stood at the end of the table and handed him each thing before he reached for it, as he had every year since 1950.

That year Gene carried the boxes over from the shop. He sat on the aisle steps among two hundred children, and when Mr. Greiner came to the end he said the end of the book, which he did not need the book for.

> *Indeed, all I can say to you at the end of these lectures (for we must come to an end at one time or other) is to express a wish that you may, in your generation, be fit to compare to a candle; that you may, like it, shine as lights to those about you; that, in all your actions, you may justify the beauty of the taper by making your deeds honourable and effectual in the discharge of your duty to your fellow-men.*
>
> *— Lecture VI*

Then Stash did the last thing, the one the children waited for all year. He bent and blew the candle out, cleanly, so that a thread of white smoke stood up from the wick. He lit a taper. He held it in the smoke, three inches above the wick and touching nothing, and the flame ran down the smoke by itself and the candle was burning again.

The children yelled. Stash did not look at it. He was already reaching under the table for the box the bell jar went in, and Gene got there first and held it open for him.

Background

The verse

> *If a man for a hundred years worship Agni (fire) in the forest, and if he but for one moment pay homage to a man whose soul is grounded (in true knowledge), better is that homage than sacrifice for a hundred years.*
>
> Dhammapada 107, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Sāriputta asks his nephew, a young Brahmin, whether he ever does a single good deed. The nephew answers that month after month he kills one animal and tends the sacrificial fire, because his teachers say this is the way to the world of Brahmā. Sāriputta tells him that neither he nor his teachers know the way, and brings him to the Buddha, who says that a hundred years of tending the fire would not come to the worth of one moment's honor paid to his disciple. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.

Upton and Riverhead, Long Island, New York

Brookhaven, 1965

Brookhaven National Laboratory was founded in 1947 in the Long Island pine barrens on the site of Camp Upton, the Army post where draftees were trained in 1917 and 1918 and inducted again in the Second World War. On November 22, 1961, ecologists there began irradiating a stand of oak and pine with gamma rays from 9,500 curies of cesium-137, raised on a pole in the middle of the woods for twenty hours of every day and lowered into a shielded hole for the other four. The experiment, led by George Woodwell, ran into the 1970s. The forest died back in rings: bare ground nearest the source, then a mat of Pennsylvania sedge, then heath shrubs, then oaks without pines, then woods that looked untouched. Pines died at exposures the oaks survived, and aphids multiplied on the stressed white oaks. Cesium-137 has a half-life of about thirty years, so a source loses roughly nine-tenths of its strength in a century. The technician's routine here, the hut, the lights and the monthly tree, is imagined around those facts.

The Laboratory had its own scientific glassblowers from its first years. Many American shops of that time were run by men trained in Lauscha and the other glass villages of Thuringia. Mr. Greiner, Stash Kozakiewicz, Gene Mroz and the children's lecture are invented. Riverhead's Polish Town grew up around St. Isidore's Church, built in 1906 by immigrants who had come to work the potato farms of eastern Long Island. Michael Faraday gave his six Christmas lectures for young people, *The Chemical History of a Candle*, at the Royal Institution in London in 1860, and the printed

text includes the relighting of a blown-out candle through its own smoke and the breath that clouds lime-water. The first sergeant who said every recruit's name right is in The Doorsill.

After the story of the elder Sāriputta's nephew from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 107). The original. Readings from Michael Faraday, *The Chemical History of a Candle* (1861). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.7

Another Man's Hat

Vale más un Dios te lo pague que un talegón de dinero.
— dicho of New Mexico (Espinosa, no. 591)

Así me lo platicaron, at the ford below San Miguel.

I. The Wagons

San Miguel del Vado, New Mexico · July 1839

The Americans stopped on the east bank that summer and unloaded. The governor had tired of counting varas of calico, and he now took five hundred pesos for every wagon that came in, large or small, full or half full. So on the flat across the river from San Miguel the traders pulled the sheets off their loads and made two wagons out of three. The empty ones stood about with their tongues on the ground until somebody bought them for the iron.

Don Ygnacio Baca rode across to them before the first bale was down. He had his English from a Kentucky trapper who had wintered in his father's house, and he wrote a fair hand in two languages. For twenty years he had done what the Americans called passing goods. He rode up to Santa Fe with each caravan and wrote out its manifests for the custom-house. He knew which inspector liked brandy and which had a daughter marrying, and when he was done the duties were arranged. Of what the law asked, a part went to the officers, a part stayed with the trader, and something reached the treasury. Each trader paid him a fee for this and thanked him. He had a saying for it, as he had for most things. *Vale más un mal arreglo que un buen pleito.* A poor arrangement is worth more than a good lawsuit.

It had made him the rich man of the valley. He had sheep out on shares with thirty families and a house with glass in two of its windows. This year, for the first time, he had four wagons of his own in the train, bought in Missouri with silver.

Two men at the river took nothing from the Americans.

One was the corporal of the guard, Tomás Padilla. The government kept soldiers at San Miguel to see that no wagon went around the customhouse, and the soldiers could be had for a twist of tobacco, all but the corporal. The Americans called him the deaf one. He walked down the line with a tally stick and counted wagons and bales, and what he counted went up to Santa Fe by a rider the same night. He and Ygnacio had herded goats together on the mesa as boys. That July he counted Ygnacio's four wagons as he counted anybody's. His count came to nine bales more than the manifest Ygnacio afterward wrote for himself, and Ygnacio paid on the nine. They had not spoken since.

The other was the old man who kept the ford. He was called tío Chano, and he was Tomás's godfather. His mother had been a Pecos woman, from the pueblo up the river whose last families had gone over the mountains to Jemez the year before. After every rise of the river he waded out with a pole and felt for where the gravel had gone, and he drove willow stakes in two rows to show it. A wagon that kept between the stakes crossed with dry axles. A wagon whose driver knew better went into the quicksand to the hubs, and the old man said nothing and went to borrow oxen. He would not take a party over at the upper bend by night, where goods went around the guard, for any money. He took nothing at the ford by day. People said the Pecos had never wet him above the knee, in flood or out of it. It was a thing people said.

II. The Year

The same village · September

SINCE THE LAST FEAST OF SAN MIGUEL, DON YGNACIO HAD been mayordomo of the función. For one year the saint's day was his to pay for, and he had paid as nobody on the Pecos had paid before him.

There were six dozen candles of white wax from Chihuahua, where other years had burned tallow. There was a keg and a half of powder from the Americans, for the salutes at vespers and at the Elevation. There was a cloak for the saint cut from a bolt of blue Missouri silk, and two fiddlers and a guitar hired down from Santa Fe, and the padre's fee for vespers, a sung Mass, a sermon and the procession. In the last week he had forty wethers killed and two beeves, and the women of nine households were baking in the ovens behind his house. He reckoned the year at a thousand pesos, which was the duty on two wagons.

He knew what he did it for. San Miguel stood over the altar with a sword in one hand and a balance in the other, and every child in the valley knew what was weighed in that balance, and when. A man who had made his living by arrangement did well to have someone standing at the scale. *Hasta para ir al cielo se necesita abogado,* he said. Even to get into heaven you need an advocate.

Two days before the feast, Tomás Padilla walked into the corral where the sheep were hanging. He had his hat in his hand, as he had always carried it in that house.

Compadre, he said. *Do you ever do one good thing?*

Ygnacio had not spoken to him since July. He swept his arm at the forty carcasses, the smoke of the ovens, the keg under its hide.

This.

What is it for?

So the saint will remember my house when he lifts the balance.

Who told you he would?

The padre. And my father, who was mayordomo three times.

The padre has not stood where that weighing is done, Tomás said. *Your father had not, and you have not. I know one man who has been across. Come down to the river.*

Ygnacio went. He could not have said why. The corporal had counted his bales in front of forty Americans, and now he walked into his corral as if nothing lay between them, and a man wants to see how far such a person will go.

III. The Ford

The Pecos · the same evening

THE OLD MAN WAS IN THE WATER TO HIS SHINS, WORKING A stake back and forth to seat it. He heard Tomás out without turning round. Then he waded to the bank and looked at the mayordomo's boots, and afterward at his face.

Is it as he says?

It is, tío.

Then listen. You have fed this valley for a week. Keep that. A hungry man's thanks is worth having. He wiped his hands down his shirt. *The rest of it, the wax and the powder and the fiddles, forty sheep killed so that people will say forty, the whole year of it, does not come to the fourth part of one thing. Take your hat off one time to a man who goes straight. Your own hat.*

Ygnacio knew to a finger's width what respect weighed. He wrote other men's letters for them. To an equal you left a fourth of the page blank down the left side, and to the governor you left half. He had never asked himself what you left for a man who drove stakes.

What straight man? he said. *On this river?*

The old man looked at his godson, who was looking at the water.

That one wrote forty when you wrote thirty-one. He lost a friend by it, and he wrote it. You have dealt in derechos for twenty years, Ygnacio, and you have arranged every one. He used the word for the duties, which is also the word for men who are straight. *Here is one that is owed to los derechos. I have looked, and there is no upper bend to carry it around by.*

He drove the stake once more with the heel of his hand.

You know the saying. Hace carabana con sombrero ajeno. He makes his bow with another man's hat. That has been your función. The hat was the governor's, and the Americans', and thirty families' of shepherds'. San Miguel can see whose hat it is.

Then he said the other one, which the women of that country say every day of their lives.

Vale más un Dios te lo pague que un talegón de dinero.

— dicho of New Mexico

A God-repay-you is worth more than a great sack of money. Ygnacio had heard it ten thousand times. He had always taken it for a thing the poor said because they had no sack.

His hat was a good one, low in the crown and covered with oilcloth, with a band of tinsel cord as thick as his thumb. He had taken it off to the Host, to the governor, to the bishop the year he came up from Durango, and to women. He took it off now. The evening wind found the place on his head where the hair was going, and he turned to the corporal.

Dios te lo pague, Tomás, he said. *For the nine bales.*

Tomás looked up from the water. Of the two of them, he was the one who did not know what to do with his hands.

And you, tío. Dios se lo pague. Twenty years you have brought my goods over dry.

Now one is paid, the old man said, and he waded back out to his stake.

It was done in a moment, and nobody saw it but a boy watering mules. Ygnacio said afterward that it was the first duty he ever paid in full, and that he came up the bank lighter than he went down, which was not how duties had worked before.

IV. San Miguel

September 29, and after

THE FEAST WAS KEPT, SINCE EVERYTHING WAS BOUGHT. THE saint went out in blue silk through the corn stubble and along the ditch with his balance swinging. The powder was burned, the fiddles played until the candles were stubs, and the whole valley ate mutton for three days. The mayordomo walked behind the saint bareheaded, as everyone did. It was noticed that he carried his hat in his hand through the dancing too.

The last of the Americans started home in the first week of October, and Ygnacio's four wagons went with them, back to Missouri for next year's goods. He rode down to see them over. In the middle of the ford the old man stood in the current with a stake in his hand, and on the far bank the corporal was counting. Ygnacio took off his hat in midstream and held it against his chest until his horse had climbed out on the other side.

The teamsters behind him were Missouri boys who did not know the country. They saw the rich man of the place uncover in the middle of the river, and they supposed it was the custom, and one after another they took off their hats to the old man in the water and the corporal on the bank.

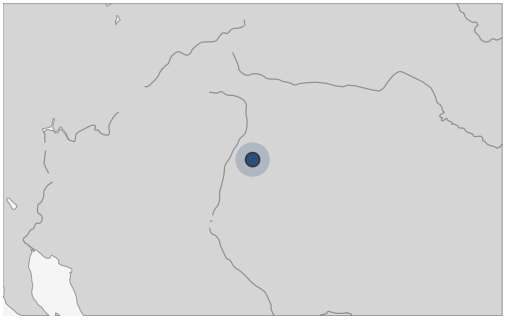
So it became the custom. For some years every wagon that crossed at San Miguel went over between the stakes with its driver bareheaded, and men who had made the crossing told others in Independence that you did it for the saint.

Background

The verse

> *Whatever a man sacrifice in this world as an offering or as an oblation for a whole year in order to gain merit, the whole of it is not worth a quarter (a farthing); reverence shown to the righteous is better.*
>
> Dhammapada 108, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Sāriputta asks a Brahmin who has been his friend whether he ever does a single good deed, and the friend answers that he offers sacrificial slaughter. It was then the custom, the commentary says, to make such sacrifices at immense expense. Sāriputta brings him to the Buddha, who asks whether he has been correctly reported and then tells him that a year of it is not worth a fourth part of what a man gains who gives alms to ordinary people with a believing heart, or who pays reverence to those who walk straight. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.



San Miguel del Vado, New Mexico

San Miguel del Vado, 1839

San Miguel del Vado, "Saint Michael of the Ford," was settled in 1794 on the Pecos River by genízaro, mestizo and Pecos Pueblo families, and its church was built in 1805. After 1821 it was the first New Mexican town the caravans of the Santa Fe Trail reached. The Mexican government stationed troops there against smuggling, and traders repacked their loads in the village before going on to the customhouse in Santa Fe. The last families of Pecos Pueblo, upriver, left for Jemez in 1838. The Missouri trader Josiah Gregg, who made the trip eight times in the 1830s, describes all of this in *Commerce of the Prairies* (1844): the guards who could be had "for a trifling *douceur*," the interpreters who made a business of "passing goods" and arranging the duties, the custom of splitting the legal tariff among officers, merchants and government, and the few years in which Governor Manuel Armijo charged a flat five hundred dollars on every wagon, large or small, so that traders took to the largest wagons they could find. Gregg also records that fords were marked out with stakes, and that in a New Mexican letter respect was measured by the width of the left margin, a fourth of the page for an equal and nearly half for a superior. By 1839 New Mexican merchants were sending their own wagons to Missouri.

The yearly feast of a village's patron saint, the *función*, was in the charge of a mayordomo who served for a year and bore its costs; in New Mexico towns such as Bernalillo a new family still becomes the mayordomos of the fiesta each year. Don Ygnacio, Tomás Padilla and tío Chano are invented, and so is the custom of uncovering in the ford. The four dichos are real. They are quoted as Aurelio M. Espinosa took them down in Santa Fe and Albuquerque and printed them in "New-Mexican Spanish Folk-Lore: Proverbs" (*Journal of American Folk-Lore*, 1913), where they are numbers 162, 386, 382 and 591. A proverb in New Mexico, Espinosa wrote, "is considered the final word on any subject."

After the story of the elder Sāriputta's friend from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 108). The original. Dichos from Aurelio M. Espinosa, "New-Mexican Spanish Folk-Lore: Proverbs" (1913). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.8

From Its Stem

> *As from its stem the cucumber, so may I be released from death, not reft of immortality.*
> *— Rig Veda 7:59:12*

Maile yasto suneko chhu, on North Hill.

I. The Lot

North Hill, Akron, Ohio · June 2016

The garden was on a double lot off Dayton Street where two houses had come down, and the county land bank leased it to the neighborhood for a dollar a year. Rupa Niroula kept the lease in a binder. She was twenty-four and a program assistant with the county Extension office, which came to a county car on Tuesdays and Thursdays, a soil probe, a box of sample bags, and forty-two raised beds full of other people's grandparents.

She had been born in Beldangi-II, in a bamboo hut in Sector C, and had landed in Akron at seventeen. The first thing she did with the lot was push the probe into it in ten places and mail the dirt to the lab. The ground along the back fence came back at four hundred and ten parts per million of lead, a hundred years of house paint, so nobody grew in the ground. They grew in boxes of trucked compost, and every March she tested the boxes too and filed the report behind the lease.

On Wednesdays, in the tool shed, she taught the hundred questions. A refugee who was old or disabled could draw a check from Social Security for seven years from the day he landed, and after that only as a citizen, and a citizen had to be able to say in English who was the Father of Our Country and what was the supreme law of the land. Most of her class had

landed in 2009. They sat on upturned buckets with the government's letters folded in their shirt pockets and said *the Constitution* after her, all together, and by the next Wednesday it had run out of them like water out of a basket. They had grown oranges and cardamom in Chirang and Sarbhang. They had been put across the border in 1992 and had sat eighteen and nineteen and twenty years in the camps in Jhapa, where there was nothing to hold on to, and they had held on. *Constitution* they could not hold.

The oldest gardener was a woman everybody called Boju, grandmother. She had bed number one, by the gate. She said she was ninety-one. Her papers gave her birthday as the first of January, like everybody else's, and no one argued with her. In Beldangi she had been the sudeni, the woman they sent for. She had caught better than nine hundred babies in that camp, Rupa among them, and when the cord was tied and cut she had said the same two words over every one. *Dirghayu hos.* Live long.

She had never come to the class. She grew cucumbers up strings, the long pale kind from home, and on each vine she let one alone. It hung there while the rest were picked, and swelled, and went yellow and then a netted brown like the skin of a russet potato. The first summer Rupa had asked whether she wanted that one picked before it spoiled.

That one's seed, the old woman said. *It'll say when.*

II. Forty-Eight Years

Schiller Avenue · the same month

Everybody on the Hill knew about Hari Prasad Timsina and told it one way. Two boys from one village in Chirang had gone off at fourteen behind a wandering baba, and for forty-eight years the pair of them kept the hard vows: one meal a day, no roof in the dry months, no woman, no money in the hand. They kept them in Bhutan. After 1992 they kept them under the pipal by the Shiva temple in Beldangi, and people coming back from the ration line touched their feet. In the forty-ninth year Hari Prasad watched the huts around him empty, family after family gone on the bus to the airport, and he thought, *There will be nobody*

OF MINE ANYWHERE. HE WALKED DOWN TO BIRTAMOD, TO A sawmill owner with three daughters and bad luck. He took water in his right palm and poured the merit of forty-eight years out of his hand into the sawmill owner's. The sawmill owner gave him a lakh of rupees and a buffalo in milk. With that he cut his hair and married Dhan Maya, who was half his age. Their son was born the next year, and in 2013 the three of them flew to Akron on the same papers as everybody else.

Now he was sixty-eight and the boy was five. Dhan Maya worked nights in a commercial laundry. Hari Prasad walked the boy to kindergarten and back, and old women on Cuyahoga Falls Avenue who had touched his feet in the camp studied the sidewalk until he had gone by. He had bed thirty, against the back fence. He grew mustard greens there and spoke to no one. They called the boy Sano, the little one. His father had not dared put a heavier name on him.

The other of the two had never left off. He had walked up to Kedarnath and down to Rameswaram and back to the camp, and in June of 2016, with the camps nearly empty, he came off a plane at Akron-Canton in an orange cloth and rubber sandals, carrying the white plastic bag the agency gives every refugee for his papers. They put him with a nephew on Schiller Avenue. People called him the Baba. Hari Prasad knew within the hour that he had come, and did not go for four days. On the fifth he took his wife and the boy and went.

He gave the boy to Dhan Maya and got down and put his forehead on the Baba's feet.

Ayushman bhava, the Baba said. May you live long.

He took the boy back, and Dhan Maya bowed. *Ayushman bhava.*

Then they stood Sano on the linoleum, and his father put a hand on the back of his head, the way it is done with small children, and the boy bowed. The Baba looked down at the part in his hair and said nothing.

You said it to me, Hari Prasad said. *You said it to her.*

Something is waiting for this one.

How long has he got?

Seven days.

Dhan Maya had the boy up off the floor before the second word was out.

Then turn it. You kept yours. I know what you're carrying.

I can read it, brother. I never learned to turn anything.

Who can?

The old woman in the garden, the one who caught the babies. Go and ask her.

She put her head on my feet in Beldangi. How do I stand in front of her with my hair cut?

If you love the boy, the Baba said, *never mind your hair.*

III. Bed Number One

Dayton Street · the next morning

RUPA WAS RESTRINGING BEAN POLES WHEN THEY CAME through the gate. Boju sat on her bucket by bed number one with a dishpan of seed garlic in her lap. Hari Prasad came down the wood-chip path ahead of his wife with his eyes on his own feet, and when he reached the bucket he got down in the chips.

Dirghayu hos, said the old woman.

Dhan Maya bowed. *Dirghayu hos.*

They set the boy down. He bowed without being pushed. Boju looked at him for some time, and then she went back to her garlic.

Hari Prasad asked her what he had asked the Baba, and she gave him the Baba's answer, down to the number.

Is there no way to turn it, Boju?

There might be.

What way?

She told him in the voice she used for how deep to set an onion. *Put up a tent in front of your door. Put one seat in the middle of it and chairs around that in a ring, eight, or sixteen if you can borrow sixteen. Have the Tryambakam said in that tent seven days and seven nights, and don't let it stop once, for food or for rain or for sleep. Said like that, it might turn the thing off him.*

A tent I can put up. Who is going to say it? I gave mine away, and I can't pay sixteen pandits for a week.

You see to the tent. I'll send my people.

She looked across the beds at Rupa. Rupa had a degree in public health from Kent State and a county badge on a lanyard, and she found she already had her phone out and was counting folding chairs.

The tent was the blue-and-white twenty-by-twenty the community association put up for weddings. The chairs were the Extension office's, sixteen of them, signed out on the form for a garden program. The seat in the middle was a pirka, a low wooden stool somebody's mother had carried from Jhapa in a suitcase. Seven days is a hundred and sixty-eight hours. Rupa ruled a sheet into fifty-six watches of three hours, eight lines to a watch, because she knew no other way to keep old people in one place, and carried it round the garden on a clipboard. Every line was full before she got to the back fence. The names on it were the Wednesday class.

IV. The Tent

Blaine Avenue · seven days

They began on a Thursday at six in the morning, in front of the duplex on Blaine Avenue where the Timsinas had the downstairs.

Om tryambakam yajamahe, sugandhim pushti-vardhanam; urvarukam iva bandhanan, mrityor mukshiya mamritat.

Eight said it and eight sat quiet between them, every other chair. A quarter of an hour before a watch ended the quiet eight took it up underneath, so that for a while sixteen were saying it, and then the first eight let go and went in to eat. It never had a seam in it. The boy sat on the pirka in the middle with a box of crayons. He slept there against a bolster, and ate there, and was carried in to the toilet and back by his father, who did not sit in the ring. Hari Prasad made the tea. At night he lay on the porch boards with one arm through the railing toward the tent.

Rupa came before work and after. She watched Mrs. Khatiwada, who in four years had not once got past *George Washington*, say the whole of it nine hundred times before noon without looking at anything. None of them looked at anything. They had it the way they had their own names.

Across the street lived a Mrs. DiPaolo, who was eighty-six and had been on Blaine since Truman. The first day she watched from her porch. The second day she crossed over and asked Rupa what they were saying. Rupa knew it in two languages, and neither one was any use to Mrs. DiPaolo. That night she found it in an old translation at the library, printed it at the office, and taped it to the tent pole in a plastic sleeve.

> *Tryambaka we worship, sweet augmenter of prosperity. As from its stem the cucumber, so may I be released from death, not reft of immortality.*
>
> *— Rig Veda 7:59:12*

Cucumber, Mrs. DiPaolo said. She read it again. *When it's ready it comes off in your hand. When it isn't, you got to twist.* She looked at the boy on his stool. Then she went home and ran a hundred feet of extension cord across Blaine Avenue from her porch outlet, with a box fan on the end of it, and all that week the cars slowed down and eased over the cord.

It rained hard on Sunday afternoon. The tent roof bellied like a basin, and two grandsons pushed the water off from underneath with a broom while the saying went on. On Monday at two in the morning a police cruiser stopped at the curb, on a call from the next street. The officer was young. There was no permit for what they were doing, because there was no form for it, and Rupa showed him the sheet in the plastic sleeve. He read it by flashlight. He asked how long. *Until Thursday.* He asked whether they could keep it down, and she told him the truth, that this was as far down as it went. He stood a while at the edge of the tent with his thumbs in his vest. The boy was asleep with his mouth open. Around him sat eight people in their seventies and eighties in shawls and knit caps, and the thing went on like water over a sill. The officer wrote something

in his book and drove off. The cruiser came down Blaine every night after that, about two, slowly, and did not stop.

V. The Seventh Night

Blaine Avenue · Wednesday

Boju had not come all week. On Wednesday at dusk she came down Blaine Avenue on her granddaughter's arm, in a white cotton sari and green rubber garden clogs, and took the chair that faced the boy.

The Hill came after her. People stood in the yards on both sides and then in the street, and Mrs. DiPaolo's porch was full of strangers. Those were the living. The ones who sat in the ring that night say it was fuller than that. They say the gods came, the great ones with their names and the small ones of springs and crossroads that only one village in Chirang had ever fed. When the great ones had taken their places there was no room left on Blaine Avenue, and the small ones had to give ground, back to Cuyahoga Falls Avenue, back out North Main to the High Level Bridge and over the gorge into Cuyahoga Falls.

Among the small ones, they say, was a yaksha who had served Kubera twelve years and had his wages in writing: *Seven days from now you may take this boy.* He had come early. He had been standing by the porch steps since Thursday with his paper in his hand. When the crowd came in he was moved back with the rest, a step, then a yard, then a mile, still holding the paper up over the heads so that someone would see it, and no one made way.

Boju said it all night and did not change with the watches. Her voice was not strong. Rupa sat on the curb and could not always find it under the others, and then toward four o'clock she could hear nothing else.

At six on Thursday the ring stopped. There was the fan, and there were birds. They woke the boy and stood him on the grass, and he bowed.

Dirghayu hos, Boju said.

Dhan Maya sat down in the street.

How long, Boju? said Hari Prasad. *How long has he got now?*

A hundred and twenty years.

So they named him over again in the tent that morning. He had been Sano. After that he was Ayubardhan, the one whose life was added to, and at school they shortened it to Ayu.

VI. Four Things

Dayton Street · September

One Wednesday in September the class never got to the hundred questions. The old people wanted to talk about the boy.

Seven days he had, and now it's a hundred and twenty years, said Mrs. Khatiwada. *There's a reason behind a thing like that. A life doesn't get longer of itself.*

Boju had come into the shed for once, out of the sun, and was sitting on a fertilizer pail by the door.

What are you all on about?

They told her.

It isn't only the years, she said. Then she gave them a line of Sanskrit, and every head in the shed came up, because each of them had it from a grandfather. Rupa had it from hers. She had never seen it in English until she looked that night.

> *He who habitually salutes and constantly pays reverence to the aged obtains an increase of four (things), (viz.) length of life, knowledge, fame, (and) strength.*
>
> *— Laws of Manu 2:121*

Manu said a good deal I wouldn't repeat to a girl, Boju said. *That one he had right.*

Four things. Rupa thought of the lab report in her binder, acidity and phosphorus and potassium and organic matter, four lines that had gone up every spring in boxes of made dirt set on poisoned ground. She kept it to herself.

Eleven of the Wednesday class took the oath the next year, some by a doctor's paper and some the long way. Mrs. Khatiwada got *the Constitution* out whole in front of the officer on her second try.

The boy is in the ninth grade at North now. On Wednesdays he interprets at the Social Security office for anybody's grandmother. He cannot get from the bus stop to his own door without stopping, because wherever he walks on the Hill there are old people looking out for him, five hundred of them if you counted, and he gets down in front of each one, in wood chips or on the sidewalk on North Main, and each one says it.

That afternoon in September, when the shed had emptied, Boju went back to bed number one. She put her hand under the brown cucumber on the first vine, only to feel the weight of it, and it came away from its stem into her palm.

Background

The verse

> *He who always greets and constantly reveres the aged, four things will increase to him, viz. life, beauty, happiness, power.*
>
> Dhammapada 109, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two Brahmin ascetics keep their austerities for forty-eight years. One of them returns to the world, sells the merit of his practice for cattle and money, marries and has a son. When the family visits the old companion, the ascetic says "Live long!" to the father and the mother and is silent for the boy, who has seven days to live. He sends them to the Buddha, who gives the same blessing and the same silence, then tells the father to raise a pavilion at his door with a seat in the middle and eight or sixteen seats around it. Monks recite the protective texts there for seven days and nights without a break, and on the last night the Buddha comes and recites until dawn. So many gods crowd in that an ogre, who had served twelve years for the right to take the boy, is pushed back and cannot reach him. The boy is promised a hundred and twenty years and renamed Āyuvaḍḍhana, "life increased." Read the full commentary story, or about paritta, the protective chanting the story describes, which Theravada monks still perform in a pavilion built for it.

North Hill, Akron, Ohio

North Hill, Akron, 2016

In the early 1990s Bhutan forced out more than 100,000 of its Nepali-speaking southerners, the Lhotshampa. Most of them spent the next two decades in camps in southeastern Nepal, among them Beldangi, Sanischare, Timai, Goldhap and Khudunabari. Resettlement abroad began in 2008, and by early 2017 more than 90,000 of the Bhutanese refugees had come to the United States. Several thousand settled in Akron, most of them in North Hill, an old Italian neighborhood; public radio's account of the first ten years describes the elders' isolation, the language barrier and the citizenship classes. The people, the garden and the week in the tent are invented.

Under the 1996 welfare law as amended in 1997, elderly or disabled refugees can receive Supplemental Security Income for seven years after arrival and after that only as citizens, which for people who arrived in 2008 and 2009 made the English civics test, drawn from a list of one hundred questions, a matter of rent. The four hundred parts per million in Rupa's soil report was the federal hazard level for lead in bare soil where children play. The verse the elders chant is the Mahamrityunjaya mantra, Rig Veda 7.59.12, said across the Hindu world for long life; it is given here in Ralph T. H. Griffith's translation of 1896. Boju's line is Manu 2.121 in Georg Bühler's translation of 1886. Its Sanskrit and the Pāli of Dhammapada 109 share their first line and two of their four increases, life and strength.

After the story of the youth Dīghāyu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 109). The original. Scripture from the Rig Veda, tr. Ralph T. H. Griffith (1896), and the Laws of Manu, tr. Georg Bühler (1886). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.9

Thirty Nobles

In small proportions we just beauties see;
And in short measures life may perfect be.
— Ben Jonson, "The Noble Nature"

I'll give it to you the way I got it, in Egypt.

I. The Garment Room

Cincinnati, Ohio · May 1984

THERE WERE THIRTY OF THEM, AND THEY HAD ALL COME TO IT late. There was a circuit judge off the bench, a druggist, the man who had the Chevrolet agency in Harrisburg, an undertaker, two superintendents from the fluorspar mines at Rosiclare, a barber, and the rest farmers. Not one had been under sixty-five when he took his fez. They were the Egypt Shrine Club, out of the river counties at the bottom of Illinois, the country people have called Egypt for a hundred and fifty years, and for five years they had driven the hospital run. It was three hundred miles to the Burns Institute in Cincinnati, by the Shawneetown bridge and Louisville, with somebody's burned child asleep on the back seat of a white Ford van, and three hundred miles home.

That spring a man from the temple at East St. Louis came down to their ladies' night and told them there were two kinds of work in the Shrine. There was the work of the ritual, the degree teams and the ceremonials, where a man got a long part by heart and gave it without the book. And there was the work of the hospitals.

Judge Harlan Oxford was eighty-four and the oldest of them. *We came to this old,* he said in the car going home. *There's not one of us will get a part by heart now. I can't keep hold of my own telephone number. But I believe we*

could do the other. Estel Belt, the undertaker, had forty acres and a dammed hollow back of Cave-in-Rock that he had never known what to do with. By the time the car reached Elizabethtown they meant to build a camp on it, six cabins and a dock, where the children from the hospital could come in summer and not be looked at.

On the next run they asked who in that building would know how to go about such a thing, and three different people sent them to the basement.

Mrs. Hauck had the garment room. She was seventy. She had cut corsets downtown for thirty years, and in 1968, when the Institute opened, somebody had the sense to hire her. A burned child, once the grafts have taken, has to wear an elastic suit that presses on the scars, twenty-three hours of the day for a year or better, or the scars rise up in ropes. Every suit is cut to the one child. Mrs. Hauck measured every child that came through the building, every inch and a half from the wrist up, and whatever the factory in Toledo sent back that did not fit she took apart and sewed over. She measured them again as they grew. There was nothing about any of them she had not had her tape around.

She heard the Judge out with her shears open in her hand.

Here is all I know, she said. *Look at the child and not at the burn. That's the whole of it. You'll be the rest of your lives at it.*

They thanked her. She asked whereabouts this lake was, and they told her, and she stood a while with the shears still open.

Go up to Three and see Mrs. Lashley before you start home, she said.

II. Pike

Three West · the same afternoon

Mrs. Lashley was the charge nurse on the acute floor, a tall Black woman from Walnut Hills who had come with the building too. She looked at thirty old men in red fezzes filling up her corridor and asked what they wanted. They said they didn't rightly know. They had been to Mrs. Hauck about a camp, and Mrs. Hauck had sent them up.

Mrs. Lashley thought about that.

Is the boy going with you?

What boy?

Then you'd better take Pike.

They all knew Pike. Half of them had been on the run that first brought him.

In January of 1977 a house on Peters Creek had burned to the stones in the night with a girl of nineteen in it, who was eight months gone. In the morning the volunteers from Elizabethtown went through the ashes with pike poles, hunting what was left of her, and one of the poles went into something that cried. He was sitting up in the bedsprings as if he had been set on a shelf. Nobody has ever said how. The hook had laid open his right eye, and the pupil of it healed with a notch at the bottom, like a keyhole. The nurses in Cincinnati called him Pike, for the pole, before anybody thought to name him, and his grandmother let it stand.

Old women in Hardin County said that a child the fire had handed back would keep his people out of want for seven generations if he stayed among them, and that if he went off he would never go anywhere without a crowd behind him.

He went up to Cincinnati every year for the surgeons to let out what had tightened, and came home, and started school. When he was seven some boys at the bus stop told him the rest of it, that his mother had burned up and he had been inside her at the time. He walked home and found his grandmother at the clothesline.

Is it so?

It's so.

Then I don't see what I want with the second grade, he said. *Take me back up there and leave me.*

She took him. It was time for his scalp in any case. The top of a child's head grows the best skin he has, and they meant to shave him and take a sheet of it for his neck. Mrs. Lashley sat on his bed the night before and gave him something to say over.

Five things, Pike. Hair of the head, hair of the body, nails, teeth, skin. That's every bit of you anybody is ever going to see. Say them down and say them back up, and each time ask yourself is any of it you.

He was still saying them in the morning when the orderly came with the razor. They tell it on Three West that at the first stroke, when the hair came away, the boy set something down and never afterward picked it up. He did not cry in the tub room after that. He was not afraid of the dark, or of the doctors, or of the mirror in the hall. The nurses got so they would put a new child's bed next to his.

Mrs. Lashley, the Judge said, *we'll be up on ladders. We can't be minding a seven-year-old with a fresh graft. He'd be in our way.*

He won't be in yours, said Mrs. Lashley. *You'll be some in his. She sent you up here so he would go along. Take him.*

So they were thirty-one going home.

III. The Lake

Hardin County, Illinois · June and July

Rosiclare was glad of them. The mines had been letting men go for ten years, and here were thirty checkbooks come to spend a summer. The lumberyard opened an hour early. The women of the four churches drew up a calendar, so that each congregation carried dinner out to the lake on its own day and none was put upon twice in a week, and for one summer the Methodists and the Church of Christ were in agreement about something.

The Judge knew old men. Thirty of them set to build six cabins will build one and talk five. On the first evening he gave the rule.

Every man takes his own job on his own piece of ground and stays on it. We're together at breakfast and we're together at supper. The hours between, a man keeps to himself and thinks on what Mrs. Hauck told us.

Eleven of them carried nitroglycerin tablets in their shirt pockets. So Bus Hobbs took the brass locomotive bell off the club's parade float and set it on a post by the dock. It was to be struck for one cause only, a man down, and at the sound of it every one of them would come.

Pike had no job. He went from one old man to the next with water in a Mason jar. He wore his tan suit under his overalls through the heat of the

day, and when Estel Belt asked him didn't it itch he said yes sir, and went on to the next man.

In the second week a stranger came out of the woods at noon, when they were all sitting along the dock with their plates. He stood off at the distance where a man can still be told to leave. He was fifty or so. He had been living on a daughter in Paducah until she could not feed him, and he was walking to another daughter in Harrisburg, and he looked to have missed several meals getting that far.

Go get you a plate, the Judge said.

He came back with a paper plate and went down the length of the dock, and every man forked over a share of what was on his own, catfish and white beans and slaw, the same as he was eating himself, no better and no worse.

When he had cleaned the plate the stranger asked, *Has somebody had you fellows to dinner? Or is it like this every day?*

About like this.

He looked at the plate. *I couldn't eat like that working double shifts. I don't know what I'd go to Harrisburg for. Let me stay and do for you.*

His name was Dewey Stallings, and he stayed two months. He burned the scrap and carried shingles and washed up after thirty-one, and nobody had a word to say against him. He learned where each man worked. He learned that they never came together between breakfast and supper, and what the bell was for.

In August he got to wanting to see the daughter. He thought that if he asked, they might talk him out of going, so he did not ask. He went up the fire road one morning before breakfast and said nothing to anyone. In two months it was the only wrong he had done them.

IV. The White Oak

Shawnee National Forest · August

The Flatheads had the woods north of the lake that week, six miles off. They were a motorcycle club out of Evansville and Paducah and East St. Louis, and when every chapter rode there were five

HUNDRED OF THEM. ON THE FOURTH OF JULY SOMEBODY IN A pickup truck had shot Dale Sisk off his machine on Route 1, and had never been found. Dale's brother Wade was their president. On the first night of the wake Wade Sisk stood up on a picnic table, with Dale's colors nailed to a white oak behind him, and swore on them that the first man to walk in on the Flatheads in that woods, whoever he was, they would kill for Dale and burn what was left.

For six days nobody came. On the seventh a prospect up in a deer stand saw a man coming along the fire road with a paper sack, and waved his arm. They let him get well in. Then they closed around him and tied his hands with a bootlace.

Somebody was building up the fire. Two more were digging.

Mister, said Dewey Stallings, *I don't see a hog anywhere. What's the pit for?*

You.

He did not think about two months of dinners. He thought about his neck.

Lord God, don't waste it on me. I'm nobody. I eat what other men leave on the plate and I always have. You could put me in that hole and not a soul would read about it. If you want it to count for your brother, there's thirty-one of them six miles south on Belt's lake. Nobles. That's what they are. It's printed on their cards. There's a judge. There's the man that owns the Chevrolet place in Harrisburg. They've got rings on them like doorknobs. Kill one of those and it'll be on the television in St. Louis.

Wade Sisk thought it over.

He's right. What does Dale want with a bum? Show us.

They left the machines at the blacktop and went in on foot behind him in the dark. The cabins stood in a row with nobody in them.

Where are they?

Scattered out. Every one sleeps by his own work. Ring that bell and they'll all come.

Wade Sisk rang it.

V. In Order

The lake · that night

They came down the paths in undershirts and suspenders, a flashlight here and there, some with the little brown bottle already in their fist, each one thinking, *Who's down?* They sat on the plank benches of the dining hall, which had a floor and no roof yet. Then they saw the men standing all around it in the trees.

Who rang that bell? the Judge said.

I did.

What for?

We swore to kill a man for my brother. One will do. You can pick him.

The Judge turned to the benches. *Boys, when brothers take a thing on, the oldest has the say. I'm eighty-four. I'll go with these men. The rest of you finish the roofs, and think on what you were told.*

Sit down, Harlan, said Estel Belt. *What the old man owes, the next one ought to carry for him. I'm eighty-one and I've buried everybody I ever cared to. It's mine.*

It went down the benches that way by age, the way they sat in lodge, every one of the thirty standing up in his turn to say it should be him. They were not kin. They were not saints either. Two of them had not spoken in nine years over a line fence. And not a man of them said, *You go.*

Then Pike got down off the end of the bench.

Y'all sit down. It's me.

Son, said the Judge, *if they shoot every one of us right here on these planks, you are not going. I would have to walk onto Three West and tell Mrs. Lashley that we carried her boy down to Egypt and handed him to a pack of thieves.*

Mrs. Hauck sent you to Mrs. Lashley, and Mrs. Lashley sent me with you. It was for this. Y'all stay.

He went along the benches and shook hands with each of them, and to each one he said, *If I did anything, I'm sorry for it.* Then he walked over to Wade Sisk.

Not one of those old men could see for crying. The Judge got hold of his voice.

Mister, he's seven. Whatever you have to make ready up there, the fire and the hole, don't let him watch you do it. Stand him off somewhere till you're through.

VI. The Ochre Bank

The forest · before daylight

THEY DID THAT MUCH. THEY PUT HIM BY A STUMP AT THE edge of the firelight with his back to it, and he sat down on the stump. He sat the way he sat in the tub room while the dressings came off, looking at nothing in front of him, and whatever they were going to hurt was not where he was.

When all was ready Wade Sisk came across with the Army Colt he had carried for eleven years and set it behind the boy's ear and pulled. The hammer fell and nothing answered. *I never seated it,* he thought. He worked the slide and set it there again and pulled, and the barrel let go. It opened from the muzzle back in four strips that curled over like the petals of a lily, and the charge went nowhere, and neither the man nor the boy had a mark on him.

Wade Sisk looked at the thing in his hand.

I've put this through an engine block, he said. *It's iron. It hasn't got a brain in it, and it knew what he was. I've got eyes, and I stood right here and didn't.*

He threw it in the leaves and got down after it on his face.

Boy. Grown men see us a mile up the road and go to shaking. Two or three of them together can't get a word out. You never so much as jumped, and your face is as bright as a new penny. Why is that? How come you're not crying?

Pike turned around on the stump.

It's like something heavy you've had on your head a long way, he said. *When somebody goes to lift it off, you aren't scared. You're glad.*

Wade Sisk got up on his knees and looked around at the five hundred.

What are you all going to do?

What are you?

I'm through with it. I saw what I saw. Where he goes, I'm going.

Then so are we.

The boy had them do it right there. They took the knives off their own belts and cut one another's hair, and cut the patch off the back of every jacket. At first light he walked them down to the creek, to the place where the clay comes out of the hill as yellow as a school bus, and had them wash, and what they wore dried the color of the suit under his overalls. Then he gave them the rules. They were the rules on the wall by the scrub sink on Three West, which were all the rules he knew. Wash to the elbow. Nobody eats before the little ones. You don't take what's on another bed. You don't say *poor thing.* Look at the child and not the burn.

He could have gone straight up the blacktop from there. He thought of the benches.

They'll be sitting down there yet, he said, *and nobody on a ladder. They think I'm in that hole. They won't drive a nail till they see me.*

So he took the five hundred back down to the lake.

Pike, said the Judge. *They turned you loose.*

They tried it and it wouldn't work, sir. Then they listened and came along. I only stopped so you'd know. Y'all go on with the roofs, and think on what you were told. I've got to take these up to Mrs. Hauck.

VII. Five Hundred

Cincinnati · the next evening

Bus Hobbs drove the van, being the youngest at sixty-six, with the boy up beside him on two cushions. Behind them the machines came two abreast for three miles. They crossed the Shawneetown bridge that way and went through Louisville, and people got out of their cars on the overpasses of Interstate 71 to watch them go under.

Mrs. Lashley was on the ambulance dock in her sweater when they came up the hill. She looked down the line as far as it went.

Pike. You brought company.

Yes, ma'am. He told her how it had been.

Take them around to Mrs. Hauck.

Mrs. Hauck came up from the basement to the front steps with the tape around her neck. She looked at five hundred men standing in the street in yellow denim with their hair cut ragged.

Pike, you have people now?

He told it again.

Is that the way it was? she asked them.

Yes, ma'am, they said.

Then hear me. One day, the way you are standing there this evening, is worth more than a hundred years of what you were at. She folded her hands on her stomach, as she must have stood to say it in the sixth grade, and gave them a thing she had had by heart ever since.

It is not growing like a tree
In bulk, doth make Man better be;
Or standing long an oak, three hundred year,
To fall a log at last, dry, bald, and sere:
A lily of a day
Is fairer far in May,
Although it fall and die that night—
It was the plant and flower of Light.
In small proportions we just beauties see;
And in short measures life may perfect be.

— Ben Jonson, "The Noble Nature"

Then she took the tape from around her neck, because the boy had grown in the shoulders since May.

• • •

They kept it. They roofed the cabins alongside the old men that fall, and the camp on Belt's lake opened the next June. On the first Sunday of October, every year since, they have come up Interstate 71 two abreast behind a white Shrine van, five hundred when all of them can come, with a stuffed bear tied on behind every saddle, and the nurses bring the children who can be moved out onto the dock to watch them pull in. The bell

is still on its post at the lake. In forty years it has been struck four times, each time for a heart.

Pike quit growing at sixteen and they let him go. At twenty-two he came back with a nursing license and took the tub room. When he had had it ten years, his cousin's boy Tim came up from Hardin County to work under him as an aide, and when the time came for Tim to go for a license of his own, Pike sent him home to the courthouse at Elizabethtown for his birth certificate, so they would have his age exact.

On a forest road back of Karbers Ridge, walking in to his folks' place, Tim came up on some men at work in a house trailer, at the kind of work that gets a stranger killed. They had him on his knees in the gravel. He talked to them the way he had heard Pike talk to frightened fathers, and in the end they let him up, on his word that he would tell no one on earth they were there. Half a mile on he met his own mother and father coming up that same road to look for him, walking straight toward the trailer. He had given his word. He let them pass.

They came home that night knocked about and robbed. *You knew,* his mother said. *You stood in the road and you knew. You're in with them.* The men from the trailer had followed to see what he would do, and they heard her through the screen door. They understood then that his word had held against his own mother. They came up onto the porch with their caps in their hands, and in the morning they drove to Cincinnati behind his car.

Mrs. Hauck was ninety-five that year, in the Lutheran home on the hill. Pike took them in to her. She asked them was that the way it was, and they said yes, ma'am, and she gave them the ten lines again from her chair without a stumble. When she had finished she held out her hand to Pike for the tape he carried in his pocket, and had him turn around, and measured him across the shoulders.

Background

The verse

> *But he who lives a hundred years, vicious and unrestrained, a life of one day is better if a man is virtuous and reflecting.*
>
> Dhammapada 110, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, thirty men who became monks late in life decide they are too old for the duty of study and ask the Buddha for a subject of meditation and leave to go to a forest. He sends them first to the elder Sāriputta, who makes them take along his seven-year-old novice, Saṅkicca. The boy had been found alive on his mother's funeral pyre, his eye marked by one of the stakes used to turn the fire, and had reached the goal of the path when the razor first touched his hair. "He will not be a hindrance to you," the elder says. "You will be a hindrance to him." The monks settle near a village, keep apart from one another, and agree on a bell to be struck only for sickness. A hungry traveler whom each of them feeds from his own bowl serves them two months and leaves without asking. Five hundred robbers who have vowed a human sacrifice seize him in the forest, and to save himself he leads them to the monks and tells them to ring the bell. Each monk in order of seniority offers to die; the novice insists it is why he was sent, asks their pardon, and goes. The robber chief's sword bends on the boy's shoulder and at the second blow splits like a palm leaf. The five hundred take the robe under the novice, who goes back to comfort the old men before he leads his following to Sāriputta and the Buddha. A second episode tells of his nephew Atimuttaka, who kept his word to a band of thieves even when his parents walked into them. Read the full commentary story.

Hardin County, Illinois

Egypt and the Shrine, 1984

The Shriners, founded in New York in 1872, are Freemasons in red fezzes whose members are styled Nobles and whose local chief is an Illustrious Potentate. They

opened their first children's hospital at Shreveport in 1922. In 1962 they voted to take on burns, and the three burn hospitals opened at Galveston in 1966 and at Cincinnati and Boston in 1968. Until 2012 no family was ever billed. Children were, and are, driven to the hospitals by Shriners in their own time. A burned child of the 1980s wore custom elastic pressure garments most of the day for a year or more, went back each year to have tightened scars released, and often gave skin from the scalp, which heals quickly. The lines Mrs. Hauck recites are from Ben Jonson's ode on Sir Lucius Cary and Sir Henry Morison, printed in 1640, as generations of schoolchildren met them in Palgrave's *Golden Treasury* under the title "The Noble Nature."

Southern Illinois has been called Egypt since the 1830s. Hardin County, on the Ohio, is the least populous county in the state; it had 5,383 people in 1980, fluorspar mines at Rosiclare that were worked until the early 1990s, a piece of the Shawnee National Forest, and at Cave-in-Rock a river cave that outlaws and river pirates used in the 1790s. The Shrine temple for the region was at East St. Louis. The Egypt Shrine Club, Belt's lake, the Flatheads and every person in the story are invented, and no hospital staff are drawn from life. Bikers' toy runs to children's hospitals, which became a fixture of American autumns around 1980, are real, and the story borrows them for its ending.

After the story of the novice Sańkicca from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 110). The original. Verse from Ben Jonson (1640), as printed in Palgrave's Golden Treasury. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.10

The Window Dummy

> *One hour's reflection is better than seventy years of pious devotion.*
> *— The Book of Ighan*

The way it was told to me, on Broadway under the el.

I. One Hour

Linden Street, Bushwick, and Eliot, Maine · spring 1977

Conrad Mayfield had loaded trucks at the Rheingold plant on Forrest Street for four years, and in the middle of January 1976 the brewery shut for good and put him out on Broadway with everybody else. He was twenty-three then. For a year he stood under the el in front of the check-cashing place with men who had thirty years in at the same plant, and he was angry all day at nothing he could have pointed to. His mother said he came into a room like a radio somebody had left on.

Mrs. Lottie Gadsden lived on the third floor at the Bushwick Avenue end of Linden Street. She had worked thirty-one years in the laundry at Wyckoff Heights Hospital, the last twenty of them beside Conrad's grandmother, and she had been a Bahá'í since 1931, when she was a young woman doing day's work in Harlem. Her faith kept no preachers, so she was not one. What she kept was Thursday night. Eight or ten people sat in her front room over tea and a plate of something, and she called it a fireside, though the building had steam heat and it was all she could do to get that. Conrad started coming for the plate. In March he signed his card.

In April she kept him back after the others had gone down.

You are all noise, Conrad. I'm not talking about your mouth.

He waited for the rest of it.

Sit down one hour every day and keep still and turn it over.

Turn what over?

Whatever's there. And I mean a whole hour off the front of the day. I don't mean the one you have left.

She also wrote a letter. There was a Bahá'í school at Eliot, Maine, on a bluff above the Piscataqua River, that took on a grounds crew for the summer sessions, and in May he went up on the bus with a duffel bag and her name to give.

He mowed. He scraped and painted porch rails on the old inn. Every morning before work he went down to a flat ledge of rock above the river and sat his hour, and for six weeks the hour was his knees and the brewery. Then on a morning at the start of July the noise stopped. He had not stopped it. He sat in what was left, which was the tide going out and a quiet he understood had been under the noise the whole time, the way a floor is under a rug. When he looked at his watch it was past noon, and the crew had eaten without him.

He told nobody at the school. There was one person he wanted to tell. He worked out the week he owed, and on Wednesday the thirteenth he took the first bus south.

II. Broadway

Wednesday, July 13 · night

It was Portsmouth to Boston and Boston to the Port Authority, and then the J train over the bridge with the windows down. A heat wave had come in and it was still in the eighties after dark. He got off at Gates Avenue a little after half past nine, and he was on the el stairs with the duffel on his shoulder when the streetlights went out. The store signs went with them, and the windows over the stores, all the way down Broadway in both directions at once. Up on the structure the train he had just left sat dead with faces at the glass.

Mrs. Gadsden's building was nine blocks off. He made four of them.

By ten o'clock there were cars backed up over the curbs with chains run from their bumpers to the store gates. A gate came off a furniture store across the avenue with a noise like a piano going down a stairwell. People ran bent double under mattresses. He saw a woman he knew from his mother's church with a carton of canned milk on her hip, and boys of ten with shoeboxes stacked to their chins, and men off the Rheingold loading dock, because half the avenue had been out of work as long as he had. Toward Halsey Street something was burning, and the engines stood across Broadway with their own lights the only lights there were.

He was not exactly afraid. But his heart was going hard, and he had been up since four, and he found he did not want to climb her stairs in that state and say what he had come three hundred miles to say with no breath to say it.

Kessler's Men's Shop had been one of the first places opened, and it was already cleaned to the walls. The plate glass was gone. What was left was the show window itself, a carpeted platform knee-high off the sidewalk, with two dummies knocked flat on it and a third standing stripped to its seams. Conrad swept the glass off a patch of carpet with the side of his duffel. He climbed up and sat with his back to the panel and his legs crossed and his hands on his knees, and began his hour.

It came quicker than it ever had in Maine. The avenue went on running and breaking a yard from his face, and he could hear every bit of it. It was only that none of it was addressed to him.

III. The Stuff

Kessler's window · after two in the morning

Nelson Ortiz was nineteen, and he and the ones with him had come sixteen blocks down from an appliance and furniture place near Myrtle Avenue. There were eleven of them by the count of those who were there. By Friday Broadway had it at five hundred, and the number has not come down since.

Each of them carried what his back would stand. Nelson had a nineteen-inch Zenith in its carton on one shoulder. His two cousins wore a

dinette chair apiece upside down on their heads. A big slow man they called Oso held a console stereo in front of him in both arms like a calf, and the smallest, somebody's brother, nine years old, had a pillowcase full of baby shoes. They had been at it since ten. Twice they had gone flat in a doorway while a patrol car rolled down the avenue with its lights off, and now there was the fire ahead at Halsey and police on foot in front of it.

That's far enough, Nelson said. *Sit down in here till it clears.*

Inside Kessler's it was as dark as the inside of a pocket. There was no moon. The floor was wet from somewhere and gritty with glass, and by feel they found that the window platform was the one clean dry place, so that was where they stacked the stuff. The Zenith went down snug against something Nelson took for a dummy. A dinette chair went against its other side. Somebody stood a carton of Pampers on its knees. The boy hung his pillowcase from its shoulder to keep the shoes off the floor, and Oso, who was the funny one, felt around until he found a hat and set it on its head.

Watch the stuff for us, pana.

Then they lay down on the carpet behind the counter. They were young and had carried a long way, and they slept.

IV. Half Past Five

Thursday, July 14

The light came in gray under the el. Nelson woke first and went to the window for his television, and the dummy under the hat was breathing.

He watched the carton of Pampers rise the width of a finger and settle. He saw eyelashes. A man was sitting in the middle of their goods with a box on his knees and a pillowcase on his shoulder and a woman's hat on, and in three hours not one thing they had put on him had shifted.

Nelson made a sound he would have denied making. The others came up behind him. The boy said *muerto.* Oso said no, it was one of those, and did not say one of what, and every one of them went for the door at once.

Don't be scared, Conrad said. He had opened his eyes. *I'm nobody. I'm a man who was praying.*

They stopped where they were, in the doorway.

We put a TV on you, Nelson said.

I see that.

You didn't feel it?

Conrad took the question seriously. *I heard you come in. It wasn't anything to do with me.*

Mister, forgive us. We took you for a dummy.

Conrad lifted the hat off and looked at it and laughed. After that the avenue called him Manny, for mannequin, and he answered to it for the rest of his life.

Nelson did not laugh. He had been running since ten o'clock with thirty pounds on his shoulder. Before that he had been running since he was fourteen, and he could not remember three minutes together when he had been still on purpose. He set the television down again.

Show me how you do that.

Me too, said Oso, and then the cousins, and the rest, and the boy said it last because he said whatever Oso said.

Conrad had known how for thirteen days. *All right,* he said. *Sit down.* He sat them in a row along the edge of the platform among the cartons, with their feet on the sidewalk, and he gave them the whole of what he had. It took under a minute to say.

Now walk with me. I have to go and tell somebody something.

V. Pupils

Linden Street · Thursday

They went up Linden Street at six in the morning carrying everything, since there was nowhere to leave it. Mrs. Gadsden was seventy-two. She came to her door in a housecoat and looked past Conrad at her stairs, which were full of boys and furniture down to the second landing.

Well, Conrad. You have got yourself some pupils.

He told her about the window. What he had come from Maine to tell her he never did get said, and he saw he did not need to.

Is that so? she asked the stairs.

Yes, ma'am, Nelson said. *We stacked a whole store on him and he never moved. We never saw anybody do like that. We want to know how he does it.*

She had them in. Nothing in her refrigerator was going to keep, so they ate all of it standing up in her front room, cold chicken and potato salad and most of a pound cake, and a half gallon of butter pecan gone soft, which went around the room with one spoon. She let them finish. Then she said the only thing she said to them that morning.

You could go on a hundred years the way you went last night. Up and down in the dark with something on your back, looking over your shoulder. Plenty do, and I'm not talking only about you. One day like you had this morning is worth more than the whole hundred.

She took down a small brown book, printed in 1904, that an old believer had put in her hands in Harlem when she was new, and she found the place without hunting for it.

> *One hour's reflection is better than seventy years of pious devotion.*
>
> *— The Book of Ighan, tr. Ali Kuli Khan (1904)*

I have had my seventy years of the devotion, Mrs. Gadsden said, *so you can take it from me.*

• • •

The goods stood in her hall until Friday, when Nelson and Oso carried the Zenith and the stereo the sixteen blocks back up Broadway. The owner was out in front of his place with a push broom. He looked at the two of them a good while, and then he pointed with the handle to where he wanted the things put down.

But Thursday was Thursday, and that night all eleven came back up her stairs. The current was still off on Linden Street. She lit four candles and the front room sat on the floor, and she read them one more place

out of the brown book, about people who had been one way and then in an instant were another.

> *...for their agitation was changed to composure, their doubt turned to assurance, and their fear transformed into courage.*
>
> *— The Book of Ighan, tr. Ali Kuli Khan (1904)*

Then she had them keep the hour, there on her floor. It was the first whole one any of them but Conrad had ever tried.

At about half past ten the current came back. The ceiling fixture came on over their heads, and the refrigerator shuddered and started up in the kitchen, and down in the street somebody cheered. Mrs. Gadsden looked around her floor. Twelve of them sat with their hands on their knees and their eyes shut, Conrad at the end by the door, and not one of them knew yet that the lights were on. She got up and blew out the candles herself, to save them.

Background

The verse

> *And he who lives a hundred years, ignorant and unrestrained, a life of one day is better if a man is wise and reflecting.*
>
> Dhammapada 111, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Koṇḍañña is given a subject of meditation by the Buddha, goes to the forest and reaches the goal there. On his way back to tell his teacher he grows tired, leaves the road, sits down on a flat rock and enters deep absorption. That night five hundred thieves who have plundered a village come by with their loot in sacks, each sack sized to the man's strength. They stop to rest at the same rock, take the seated elder for a tree stump, set one sack on his head and pile the rest around him, and sleep. At dawn they see what he is, think him a spirit and start to run; he tells them not to be afraid. They beg his pardon, and all of them ask to go forth under him. He is called Khāṇu, "Stump," ever after. When he brings them to the Buddha, the Buddha asks, "You have obtained pupils?" and tells the former thieves that one day lived in the wisdom they have just found is better than a hundred years of last night's foolishness. Read the full commentary story.

Bushwick, Brooklyn, New York

Bushwick, July 1977

Lightning north of the city began knocking out transmission lines at 8:34 on the evening of July 13, 1977, and by 9:37 the whole Con Edison system was down. Power was not fully restored until late the next night. The blackout came in a heat wave, in the middle of the city's fiscal crisis, and thirty-one neighborhoods saw looting. Bushwick was among the hardest hit. Along Broadway, under the elevated tracks that divide it from Bedford-Stuyvesant, 134 stores were looted and 45 of them burned, and some two dozen fires were still going in the morning; gates were pulled off storefronts with chains run to car bumpers. The neighborhood had been losing its work for years. The Rheingold brewery on Forrest Street, one of its last big employers, closed for good in January 1976. Kessler's Men's Shop, Mrs. Gadsden and everyone else in the story are invented.

The Bahá'í Faith has no clergy. Its teaching in America has gone on largely in living rooms, at informal evenings long called firesides. Green Acre, on the Piscataqua River at Eliot, Maine, was founded by Sarah Farmer in 1894 as a summer conference on religion; ʻAbdu'l-Bahá stayed there for a week in August 1912, and it has been a Bahá'í school since. The book Mrs. Gadsden reads from is Bahá'u'lláh's Kitáb-i-Íqán, written in Baghdad in the early 1860s, in its first English translation, The Book of Ighan, made by Ali Kuli Khan and published in New York in 1904. The line about one hour's reflection is an old Islamic tradition that Bahá'u'lláh quotes there. Later Bahá'ís have read the book in Shoghi Effendi's translation of 1931; an American believer of Mrs. Gadsden's generation could still have owned the older one.

After the story of the elder Khāṇu Koṇḍaññā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 111). The original. Scripture from The Book of Ighan (the Kitáb-i-Íqán of Bahá'u'lláh), translated by Ali Kuli Khan (1904). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.11

The Second Razor

We live in deeds, not years; in thoughts, not breaths;
In feelings, not in figures on a dial.
— Philip James Bailey, Festus (1839)

The way it came down the line, on the Overland.

I. George

The Overland Limited, eastbound · May 1907

Julian Coates had the barber's chair in the buffet car of the Overland Limited, and there was not a colored man in the service between Chicago and Oakland Pier who would not have changed places with him. The car rode at the head of the train. It had a baggage room, then a closet with a tin bathtub, then his own cubicle with the chair and the glass and the shelf of bottles, then the library with its leather seats, where he served whiskey and seltzer to gentlemen who were three days crossing the country. A shave was a quarter. Most of them left another quarter on the shelf.

His father had been a barber too, in Xenia, Ohio, with three chairs and a white trade, and was called Mr. Coates on Detroit Street by men who called no other colored man mister. He had put Julian two years into Wilberforce to make a teacher of him. Then he died. A German took the trade, and the chairs were sold. Julian heard a Pullman man speak at the church one Sunday on seeing the whole of the country from a moving window, and he believed it, and at twenty he went on the cars with his father's razors in a roll of green baize.

That was seven years back. He had seen the whole of the country three hundred times since, and in all of it he was George. Every porter on every

car was George, after Mr. Pullman, so that no passenger need learn a name. There was a book of rules as thick as a hymnal. There were men the Company sent to ride as passengers and write down what the help did. He stood eighteen hours of the twenty-four, and slept sitting up, and answered.

He could not go home. His mother told it every Sunday that her son was with the Pullman Company on the Overland Limited, and it was the proudest thing in that congregation. A man with two years of Wilberforce does not go back to Xenia to black the boots of the men his father shaved. And he had come to think he would sooner be dead than be George for one more year. He held those two things together and there was no door between them. From about Christmas on he went through his work looking at the couplings, and the bridge at Omaha, and the wheels of the freights that went by on the next track, considering.

II. The Crock

Nevada · morning

They took coal for the kitchen range at Winnemucca before daylight. When the fourth cook went to the coal box to make up the fire for breakfast, something in it sang at him like a kettle. It took three of them to get it out. The second cook pinned it with the poker, and it struck the iron twice, and a waiter got it by the tail with a dish towel and dropped it into a two-gallon butter crock, and they put the lid on and tied the lid down.

Julian came through from the buffet car after he had eaten, and met them in the passage carrying the crock between two men.

What have you got?

Snake. Rattler, as long as your arm.

What do you mean to do with it?

Pitch it off.

He stood there a moment. *Give it here,* he said. *I'll pitch it. I've got the baggage door.*

They were glad enough to hand it to him. He carried it forward through his own car, past the chair, and into the baggage room, and shut the door behind him, and ran the side door open a foot so that the sagebrush went by in a grey strip. He sat down on a drummer's trunk with the crock between his shoes and untied the towel and lifted the lid.

It lay in the bottom in a coil. He put his hand in. He laid it on the snake's back, and the snake let it lie there. He stirred his hand around in the crock, this way and that, as you would stir a pan of wash water to find the soap. He took the head between his thumb and two fingers, and opened the mouth, and put his first finger inside it and held it there while the train ran a mile.

Then he took his finger out and looked at it. *You're no rattler,* he said. *You're a gopher snake,* and he tipped the crock out through the door into the sage.

In the kitchen they asked him had he got rid of it.

That was no rattlesnake. It was nothing but a gopher snake.

Gopher snake! the second cook said. *It had nine buttons on its tail and it rang every one. It hit that poker twice. You saw the three of us sweating over it. What makes you say such a thing?*

I tried to get it to bite me. I had my finger in its mouth, and it wouldn't close on it.

Nobody in the kitchen said anything to that. The fourth cook went back to his potatoes.

III. The Headrest

The Lucin Cutoff, Great Salt Lake · that night

A freight was on the ground at Carlin, and they sat behind it six hours. So it was past midnight, and not the middle of the afternoon, when the Overland came down out of the desert onto the lake.

Late at night, with the gentlemen in their berths, Julian cut the crew's hair. The rule book did not allow for it, and old Mr. Tolbert, who had the rear sleeper and thirty-five years on the cars, did. They came forward one at a time, porters and waiters, and sat in the chair with a towel round the

neck. He worked with two razors. One he used, and the other lay open on the shelf under the glass to be taken up when the first lost its edge. That night the first held. When the last man had gone back through the train he wiped it and closed it, and reached to close the second, and stood with it in his hand.

He sat down in his own chair. He let his neck back onto the headrest, where four thousand white men had laid theirs, and set the blade under his jaw at the windpipe, and looked up into the glass.

The car had come out onto the trestle. There are twelve miles of it, on piles, with the lake flat on both sides and no shore to be seen, and the moon was straight overhead, so that it stood in his window once in the sky and once in the water.

He meant to do it on a count of ten. Instead of counting he found that he was going back along the seven years, the way a porter walks back through his car at the end of a run to see what has been left in the berths. He was looking for the thing he ought to be ashamed of.

He had never kept a dime that was not handed to him. There had been watches under pillows, and a diamond pin in a washbowl at Reno, and a lady's purse with four hundred dollars in it, and every one had gone to the conductor with a slip. He had never had a drink on the car, or sat down to the dice in the quarters at Oakland. He had never told a Company man one word about another porter. He had sent his mother eighteen dollars on the first of every month. He had been called out of his name ten times a day for seven years, and worse than George, and had not once said the thing back. He had held this same edge to the throats of men who had called him those things an hour before, and had not nicked one.

He went down the whole length of it, berth by berth, and there was nothing left lying in it. It was clean. It was as clean as the moon out there on the water, as the row of glass bottles on his shelf with the lamp behind them.

All that time he had supposed he was keeping the Company's rule. He saw whose it was.

A gladness came up through him then from the soles of his feet, so strong that his hand shook, and the edge moved on his skin. He held still under it. He looked at the gladness the way he would look at a lather to see if it was right. He looked at the neck, and the blade, and the man in the glass they called George, and at Julian Coates of Xenia, and at the one who had wanted to be dead since Christmas. They came and went in the glass like stations. There was none of them he was obliged to carry.

He took the razor down from his throat, since there was no one left in the chair that needed killing, and closed it, and went back through the train.

IV. The Step-Box

Promontory Point to Ogden · toward morning

THE DINING-CAR CREW WERE AT THEIR OWN SUPPER, WITH TWO or three of the Pullman men.

Where did you get to, Coates?

I was in my chair with this on my neck. He had the razor in his hand yet. *I went in there to cut my throat.*

Then how is it you're standing up?

I couldn't do it now. I couldn't do harm with an edge to anything living. I went to cut my windpipe, and I cut the other thing instead, the thing that wanted it done.

They looked at one another. *First it's a rattlesnake that won't bite him,* the second cook said, *and now this. The man is telling tales.* And since there was one place on that train where such a matter was taken, they got up from the table and took it there.

Mr. Tolbert sat up nights in the smoking room of the rear sleeper, under the call board, with a soap box of books beside him that passengers had left in berths since 1872. He heard the cook and then he heard Julian, and he looked at Julian for some time.

He's telling you the truth, he said. *A man who has come clear the way he says can't take his own life. There is nobody in him to lift the hand.*

You call Coates clear? Mr. Tolbert, he has been the lowest man on this train since Christmas. If he had that in him, what was he so low about? And what kept that snake off him?

The snake is the least of it. Where I was raised, the old people would have told you that snake had worked for him once, three lifetimes back, and still knew better than to raise its head to him. I don't ask you to believe them. I only say it never bit him.

For the lowness, some of you remember Sim Purdy, who had the next car to his. Coates was low once before, his first year out, and it was Sim who talked him round. Told him what there was for a colored man off the cars, till he was content to stay on them. Then one day Coates was honing his daddy's razors, and he said, Sim, when I was fixing to quit I had it in mind to leave you these. After that Sim sang another tune. What does a man want with this life, he says. Can't sit down in the car he sweeps. Sees his wife four days in the month. He sang it every trip, till Coates was as low as before and lower. It took the boy a year to ask himself why the tune had changed, and then he saw it. Sim wanted the razors, and the chair along with them. But a thing like that gets in a man and stays. That is where the lowness came from.

And the other came from seven years of keeping straight when he had no joy in it and nobody watching. That is money in the bank whether a man knows he has an account or not.

Mr. Tolbert, said the waiter who had held the snake's tail, *a man can't get all that done in the time it takes to hold a razor to his neck.*

He can get it done between the step-box and the platform. He can lift his foot off the one, and be through before it comes down on the other.

He took his watch out and opened it. *By this we are six hours and ten minutes late. That is all it knows.* Then he reached into the soap box for a green book with the back gone, which a schoolteacher had left in Lower 6 somewhere west of Laramie in 1881, and read to them out of it.

One generous feeling — one great thought — one deed
Of good, ere night, would make life longer seem
Than if each year might number a thousand days, —
Spent as is this by nations of mankind.
We live in deeds, not years; in thoughts, not breaths;
In feelings, not in figures on a dial.
We should count time by heart-throbs. He most lives
Who thinks most — feels the noblest — acts the best.

— Philip James Bailey, Festus (1839)

A man can lie in his berth a hundred years, Mr. Tolbert said, *and not have lived as much as this one did tonight between Lakeside and Midlake. Go on to bed.*

V. Snake

Ogden, Utah · daylight

The dining-car crew went off at Ogden and told it in the yard, and it reached Omaha ahead of the train. From that trip on he was Snake Coates on every road that carried a Pullman car. He stayed forty years in the service and answered to that, and to George, and to his own name when it was offered, and it was all one to him which.

They lay an hour at Ogden for the Union Pacific engine. The sun was coming up behind the Wasatch when Mr. Tolbert walked the length of the train to the buffet car and sat down in the chair and put his neck back on the headrest.

I'll have a shave, Mr. Coates, he said.

Julian took the second razor off the shelf and tried it on his thumb and laid it under the old man's jaw.

Background

The verse

> *And he who lives a hundred years, idle and weak, a life of one day is better if a man has attained firm strength.*
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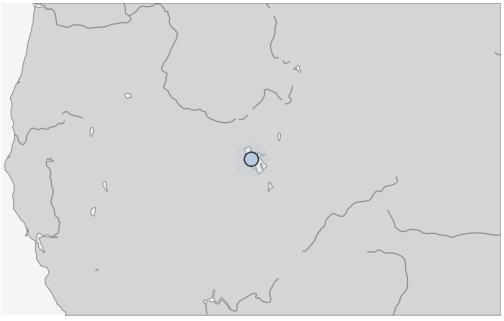
> Dhammapada 112, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young man of good family becomes a monk, grows discontented, and decides that going back to lay life would be beneath him and that death would be better than staying. When the monks catch a snake in the hall where the fire is kept and carry it out in a jar, he offers to throw it away, and tries to make it bite him, even putting his finger in its mouth. It will not, and he tells the others it was only a house snake. He is also the monastery's barber. One day he takes his second razor to a tree, leans his neck on a branch and sets the blade to his windpipe. There he reviews his conduct since his ordination, finds it as spotless as the moon's disk, is filled with joy, and attains the goal. The monks think he is lying. The Buddha tells them that one who is freed cannot take his own life, that the snake had been the man's slave three lives earlier, and that his discontent went back to a former life in which a fellow monk who coveted his bowl and robes talked him out of his vocation. Asked whether so much can happen in so short a time, he answers that it can happen between lifting a foot and setting it down. The monk was afterward called Sappadāsa, "he whose slave was a snake." Read the full commentary story.



Great Salt Lake (Lucin Cutoff), Utah

The Overland Limited, 1907

The Overland Limited ran between Chicago and San Francisco Bay over the North Western, the Union Pacific and the Southern Pacific. Its advertisements in 1902 promised "Buffet-Library Cars (with Barber and Bath)," an electric reading lamp in every berth, and dining cars for all meals. From 1904 the train crossed the Great Salt Lake on the Southern Pacific's Lucin Cutoff, 102 miles from Lucin to Ogden, nearly

twelve of them on a wooden trestle with a station called Midlake in the middle of the water.

The Pullman Company staffed its cars with Black men, and passengers called every one of them George, after George Pullman. Pullman porters were paid too little to live on without tips, worked something like four hundred hours a month, and could be suspended on the word of a Company inspector; they did not win a union contract until 1937. The job was nonetheless among the best open to Black men, and many who held it had some college. Julian's father belongs to an older elite, the Black barbers who served white customers in Northern towns and who were losing that trade to European immigrants around 1900. Wilberforce, near Xenia, Ohio, is the oldest of the African Methodist Episcopal colleges. Philip James Bailey's *Festus* (1839) went through many American printings, and its line about deeds and years was copied into autograph albums for half a century; the passage is given here from a New York edition of 1872. Julian Coates, Mr. Tolbert and the wreck at Carlin are invented.

After the story of the elder Sappadāsa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 112). The original. Verse from Philip James Bailey's Festus (1839; New York edition of 1872). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

8.12

Spilt Water

For we must needs die, and are as water spilt on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again.
— 2 Samuel 14:14

The way I heard it told, on the muck.

I. The Upstairs Room

Chosen, Florida · 1925

Josiah Pinder came over from Andros on a sponging schooner when he was fourteen with one shirt and a cane knife, and by the time he was fifty he was the richest colored man on the lake. He had cut cane, and picked beans on his knees in the black muck by the hamper, and saved, and bought a truck, and hauled other men to the fields in it at a dime a head, and bought another truck. Now he had three trucks and a store in Chosen with a gallery on the front and a boarding house behind it with twenty rooms, and a two-story house of Dade County pine on the canal bank, painted white, the only painted house in the quarters. He was a class leader at the African Methodist church and could recite the General Rules from the Discipline without looking, and he did, often.

His daughter Ozella lived on the second floor of the white house. She had been born in it. At sixteen she was the prettiest girl on the south shore of the lake, and her father knew exactly what the south shore of the lake was. There were jook joints on every road out of Belle Glade, and men who came in for the bean season with knives in their boots and left without paying their board, and the muck was full of trouble. So he kept her upstairs. She had her own room with a window on the canal and a

bed with a store-bought spread, and her Aunt Bertha to sit with her and see that she stayed in it. She went to church and to the store and to the schoolhouse until she was fourteen, and nowhere else. In the spring of 1925 her father promised her to a young man from West Palm Beach whose father taught school, a young man who wore a collar on weekdays, and they set the wedding for the first Sunday in June.

Cleon Hardy drove Josiah Pinder's best truck. He was from Thomasville, Georgia, and had no people on the lake and no money, and three times a week he carried the groceries up the back stairs to Aunt Bertha's kitchen and set them on the table. For a year he had done it. For a year Ozella had stood in the kitchen door while he did it.

Ten days before the wedding she said it to him on the back stairs, low, while Aunt Bertha was in the pantry.

Once I'm in that man's house in West Palm, you can bring me all the groceries in the world and you won't ever get in the door. If you mean it, get me out of here. Don't wait.

Tomorrow, said Cleon. *First light. I'll be at the canal bridge.*

She got up in the dark. She put on the oldest dress she had, one her aunt had cut down for rags, and took her shoes off and left them by the bed, and rubbed muck on her face and her arms and her feet until she looked like any girl who had come in off a bean field. Then she took the slop bucket and went down the back stairs as if she were going to empty it, and two of the boarding-house women were out at the pump, and they looked straight at her and did not see her. She set the bucket down at the end of the yard and walked out to the canal bridge, and Cleon was there with a borrowed Ford, and they went north up the lake on the Conners toll road with the sun coming up out of the sawgrass on the right hand, and they did not stop until Okeechobee.

II. The Fish Camp

The north shore · 1925–1928

They married at the courthouse in Okeechobee, and Cleon got on at a fish house on Taylor Creek, cleaning catfish for the fish

CARS THAT WENT NORTH ON THE RAILROAD, AND THEY TOOK A shack on stilts at the edge of the camp. Ozella hauled water from the creek in a lard bucket. She washed clothes in a tub and scrubbed fish scales off Cleon's overalls with lye, and cooked on a kerosene stove that smoked, and learned to cut wood. She had never cut wood. Her hands had never been hard. The women at the fish camp laughed at her the first month, and then stopped laughing and showed her how, and that was where she learned what it cost to live, which she had not known in the white house.

She was happy. She would say so, afterward, when she could say anything. She had been happy.

When the first baby was due, in the summer of 1926, she began to ask him.

I want to go home to have it. There's nobody here. A mother and a father always come around for a grandbaby. Take me home.

Your daddy will kill me, said Cleon. *You know he will. He'll get his pistol out from under the counter in the store and shoot me in the road in front of everybody, and the sheriff won't even come out for a thing like that. I can't go back there.*

She asked him every day for a month. Every day he said the same. So one morning while he was at the fish house she told the woman in the next shack, *If Cleon asks where I've gone, tell him home,* and she shut the door and started walking south down the toll road toward Chosen, forty miles off. Cleon came after her in a borrowed truck and caught her up a few miles below town and begged her to get in, and she would not get in. While they were standing in the road arguing, the pains came on. She went in among the palmettos and lay down on the sand, and had her son there, by herself, with Cleon outside the palmettos walking back and forth.

When it was over she came out with the baby wrapped in her slip.

Well, she said. *What I was going home for is done.* And she got in the truck and they went back to the fish camp.

They called him Josiah, for her father, who did not know he existed.

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In the summer of 1928 she was carrying again, and she asked again, and he said the same thing again, and in the middle of September, when she was near her time, she took Josiah on her hip, who was two, and told the woman next door, and shut the door, and started south on the toll road.

It had rained for weeks. The lake was higher than anyone at the fish camp could remember, up near the top of the little muck dike, and the radio in the fish house had been talking about a storm in the islands since Thursday. The storm was supposed to have come and gone already, out to sea. People were laughing about it.

Cleon came after her and caught her up on the Saturday afternoon, below Port Mayaca, and she would not get in the truck, and the truck would not start again, and they walked on together down the shore road with the boy between them.

III. The Storm

The east shore of Lake Okeechobee · Sunday, September 16, 1928

The wind came up on Sunday afternoon out of the northeast, and the rain came with it, and by dark there was no telling one from the other. The sky went white with lightning and stayed white, and the thunder came on top of it so close that Ozella felt it in her teeth. The sawgrass lay down flat. The lake, on their right hand, which had been gray and quiet all day, stood up and began to come over the road.

Then her pains started.

Cleon. It's coming. I can't walk. Find me something. Find me a place out of this.

He had the axe from the truck. There was a spoil bank by the road where they had dug a ditch years before, and on top of the spoil bank was a clump of palmetto and myrtle, the only thing standing up out of that whole flat country. He put her down in the lee of it with the boy and went up the bank with the axe to cut fronds for a lean-to. She saw him in the lightning, up on the bank, swinging. She saw him stop.

The moccasin had come up out of the roots of the palmetto to get out of the water, and it was as thick as a man's wrist, and it struck him in the calf and then again in the hand. By the next flash he was down on his knees. He tried to come down the bank to her. He did not get there. In the lightning she saw his arm go purple and swell, and his face, and then he was lying on the spoil bank with the axe under him, and he did not get up again, and she could not go to him.

She waited for him to come back. She knew he was not coming back. She waited anyway.

The baby came in the middle of the night, in the rain, on the sand in the lee of the bank, a boy. She had nothing to wrap him in but her own dress. The wind screamed across the top of the spoil bank all night and the rain came sideways, and both children screamed with it, the new one and Josiah, so loud she could hear them over the storm, and she got down over the top of the two of them on her hands and knees, with her knees pressed together and her elbows in the sand and her body over them like a roof, and stayed there until the sky went gray. By morning there did not seem to be any blood left in her. Her skin was the color of a dead palmetto frond.

Away to the south, all that night, across the black water, she had heard something she could not put a name to. A long roar, under the wind. She did not know until later that it was the lake coming over the dike at Belle Glade and South Bay and Chosen.

IV. The Canal

The shore road · Monday morning

At first light the wind dropped. She took the new baby, who was red all over as a piece of fresh meat, and put him on her hip, and gave Josiah her finger to hold.

Come on, baby. Your daddy's gone on ahead of us.

She went up the spoil bank the way he had gone. He was lying there on top of it in the gray light, swollen, purple, stiff, with the axe under him and the palmetto half cut.

On account of me, she said. *On account of me you died out here on the road.* She said it over and over, walking. She did not stop walking.

A mile on, the road went down under the water where a canal came out of the lake. The rain had filled it all night. It was over her knees where the road had been and up to her waist in the middle, and moving, brown, with sawgrass and boards and a drowned hog going by in it. She could not carry them both. She was too weak to carry one. So she sat Josiah down on the road on the near side and told him to be still, and waded across with the baby held up high, and on the far side she broke a branch off a myrtle and laid it down on the bank and laid the baby on the leaves.

Then she started back for Josiah. In the water she kept turning around to look at the baby. She could not stop. Every three steps she looked back.

She was in the middle, up to her waist, when the hawk came down out of the sky. A big brown chicken hawk, that had been hanging over the flooded country all morning looking for what the storm had left. It saw something red on a green branch. It came down on it.

She threw both her arms up out of the water and screamed. *Get away! Get away! Get away!* Three times. The hawk was too far off. It took the baby up off the branch and went up with him, heavy, low over the sawgrass, and away.

On the near bank, Josiah saw his mother stop in the middle of the water and throw up her arms and scream. He thought she was calling him. He was two. He came running down the road to her into the water, and the water took him off his feet and turned him over once and took him down the canal, and she saw his little shirt once in the brown, and then she did not see it.

She got out on the far side somehow. She did not remember getting out.

One of my boys a hawk took, she said, walking. *One the water took. And my husband is lying dead on the road.*

V. The Smoke

Above Canal Point · later in the week

She did not know how many days she walked. She slept on the road. People went by her in trucks going north and boats going south. On the third day, or the fourth, she met a man walking north along the dike road, a colored man in a white shirt gone gray, with a sack over his shoulder, coming up out of the south shore.

Mister. Where are you coming from?

Chosen, sister. What's left of it.

In Chosen, in the white house on the canal, by the store, there's a family named Pinder. Do you know them?

He stopped. *I know them. Don't ask me about them, sister. Ask me about anybody else in Chosen and I'll tell you.*

I don't want to know about anybody else in Chosen. That's the only one I want to know about.

The man looked at her for a long time. He put his sack down. *You didn't leave me any way out of it,* he said. *You felt it rain Sunday night?*

Felt it. Mister, I'm the only one in the world it rained on Sunday night. I'll tell you about it some time. Tell me about the Pinders and I won't ask you anything else.

Sunday night the water came over the dike, he said, *and the wind took that white house up off its blocks and turned it over, and it came down on Josiah Pinder and his wife and their boy Eldridge, all three, and they died under it. They found them Tuesday. There's too many to bury down there, sister. No coffins. They're saving the coffins for the white folks. The ones of us they find, they're stacking them up with the wood from the houses and burning them, all together. They're burning Chosen right now.* He turned and pointed back the way he had come. *Look yonder. That's the smoke.*

She looked. Away down at the south end of the lake, over the flat drowned country, a column of black smoke was going up into the white sky and leaning over at the top in the wind.

Something went out of her then.

Her dress had been rotting on her for days, torn on the palmettos, soaked and dried and soaked, and now it came apart and fell off her and she did not know it. She walked on down the dike road naked in the sun, round and round, around the trucks and the boats and the people, crying and saying it out loud, the same thing, over and over, like a song somebody had taught her.

Both my boys gone. My husband dead on the road. Mama and Papa and my brother burning up all in one fire.

People on the road yelled at her. *Crazy woman! Look at that crazy woman!* Some of them threw things. Muck off the road, wet, in clods. Children threw it. It hit her in the back and in the hair, and she did not know that either.

VI. Forbid Her Not

West Palm Beach · October 1928

The refugees from the lake had been brought out to West Palm Beach by truck and boat, the colored ones to the colored side of town, and on the lot beside one of the colored churches there was a tarpaulin stretched between two trees where an old woman sat on a kitchen chair every evening with the people from the muck sitting on the ground around her.

Her name was Lettie Brinson. She was seventy-three. She had been born a slave in Madison County and licensed as an evangelist by the African Methodist Episcopal Church in 1889, the year Ozella's father came over from Andros, and in forty years she had preached in turpentine camps and phosphate camps and convict camps from the Georgia line to Key West, but she was past most of that now. Now she sat on the kitchen chair. She did not preach much anymore. People came and sat by her anyway, because she listened, and because when she did say something it was usually the one thing.

They had been to Tamarind Avenue that week, some of them, where the trucks from the lake had brought six hundred and seventy-four colored dead and laid them in one long trench with no service said. They

had come back and sat by Lettie Brinson under the tarpaulin and not said anything at all.

Lettie saw Ozella a long way off, coming down the street in the late sun with nothing on and muck in her hair and a crowd of boys behind her throwing things.

She knew her. She had seen her once before, though Ozella would not remember it. At a camp meeting on the lake in 1919 a little girl in a white dress had stood at the edge of the brush arbor with her father and watched Lettie Brinson take an old woman by the hand and stand her up in front of the whole meeting and give her the class book to keep. The old woman knew the Discipline better than any preacher on the lake. Lettie said so. And the little girl had pulled at her father's coat and said, loud enough for everyone to hear, *I want to be the one that knows it best,* and the people had laughed, and Lettie had not.

That's her, said Lettie Brinson to nobody. *She's here.*

The people under the tarpaulin saw what was coming down the street and got up. *Mother, don't let her in here. That's a crazy woman. Somebody run her off.*

Let her come, said Lettie. *Get out of the way. Forbid her not.*

They got out of the way. Ozella came in under the tarpaulin still saying it, *both my boys gone, both my boys,* and stood in front of the kitchen chair, and the old woman looked up at her.

Daughter, she said. *Come back to yourself.*

And Ozella came back.

The people who were under the tarpaulin that evening told it the rest of their lives, and none of them ever told it any differently. The old woman said four words, and the girl came back into her own eyes the way a lamp comes up when you turn the wick. She looked around her. She looked down. She saw that she had nothing on, and she dropped down on the ground and wrapped her arms around her knees, and the shame came into her face, which was the first thing that had come into it in a week.

A man by the tree took off his coat, a brown suit coat with the lining torn, and threw it to her. She put it on. Then she came on her knees

across the dirt to the kitchen chair and put her forehead down on the old woman's shoes.

Help me, she said. *Mother, help me. Hold me up. One of my boys a hawk took and the other one the water took. My husband's dead on the road at Port Mayaca. The storm turned my daddy's house over and it fell on him and my mama and my brother and they're burning them in one fire at Chosen. I saw the smoke.*

Lettie Brinson heard all of it. She did not hurry it. When it was done she put her hand on Ozella's head, on the muck in her hair.

Be still, now. You've come to the right place. All you said is so. A hawk took one, and the water took one, and your husband's dead on the road, and your mama and your daddy and your brother are gone in that fire. It's so. Now hear me. You aren't the first. Every woman that ever lived on that lake has cried over somebody. Every woman back to Eve. You put all those tears together, daughter, and there's more of them than there was water in Okeechobee. More than came over the dike. You've been crying a long, long time, longer than you know. It's time to stop being careless with yourself.

Ozella stayed on her knees with her head on the old woman's shoes. After a while the crying in her went down, a little, the way the lake had gone down a little by Wednesday, not enough to see a road but enough to know where the road was.

Lettie felt it go down and went on.

Your children couldn't hold you up, daughter. Your daddy couldn't. Your husband couldn't. Nobody's people can hold them up when the end comes for them. Not when it's here, and not after, and not anywhere. The Book says it.

> *None of them can by any means redeem his brother, nor give to God a ransom for him.*
>
> *— Psalm 49:7*

So don't lean on them. You know now. Clear your own road while you've got the light, and walk it. That's all there is to do.

Ozella lifted her head off the shoes. Something had moved in her that would not move back. The people under the tarpaulin could see it,

though they could not have said what it was, and some of them, sitting on the ground with their own dead in them, felt it move in themselves.

Let me stay with you, said Ozella. *Let me be one of your women.*

Lettie Brinson sent her to the deaconesses at the church that night, in the man's brown coat, and they washed the muck out of her hair and gave her a dress.

VII. Three Pourings

Belle Glade · 1934

She was consecrated a deaconess of the African Methodist Episcopal Church at the annual conference in the spring of 1930, in a plain black dress with a white collar. People had stopped calling her the crazy woman by then, and most of them had stopped calling her Ozella. They called her Sister Pinder. The women at the church in West Palm said that in two years she had learned the Discipline better than any preacher in the conference, and they were not exaggerating. She knew every rule in the book and the reason behind every one, and she could tell a young woman what was right without making her feel like dirt for not knowing it, which is harder.

In 1932 she asked to go back to the lake, and they let her.

The Army engineers were building the big dike around the south shore by then, a long wall of rock and earth higher than a house where the little dike had been, and the bean fields had come back, and the pickers had come back, from Georgia and the Carolinas and the islands, and the jooks had come back, and the girls of sixteen, and their trouble. Sister Pinder had a room behind the church in Belle Glade. The girls came to her there. She sat with them on the back step.

One evening in the summer of 1934 she came in from the fields hot, with muck to her ankles, and sat on the back step and filled the enamel pitcher from the pump to wash her feet.

She poured the first pitcher over her feet, and some of it went past them onto the ground. It ran a little way on the hard-packed sand, a hand's width, and soaked in and was gone.

She poured again. The second time it ran farther, a foot or more, toward the pump, and then that sank in too.

She poured the third time. The third time it ran farther yet, almost to the pump, a long dark thread across the yard, and stopped, and she watched it go into the ground and the ground go pale again where it had been.

She sat with the empty pitcher in her lap and looked at the three marks.

The little one was the baby on the myrtle branch. The water had not run a hand's width with him. The second was Josiah and Cleon and her brother Eldridge, who had all run a little way, a little farther, and gone in. The third, the long one, was her mother and her father and Aunt Bertha and Lettie Brinson, who had all run about as far as water can run in this world before it goes into the ground. And she knew which line she would be. She would be one of those three. Everybody was. The ground was taking all of them. The ground had been taking them all along, every day, since before she was born, and she had not been looking. She had been looking at the water, and never at where it went.

Some words came up in her that she had read years before in the upstairs room, in the Book, without knowing she had kept them.

> *For we must needs die, and are as water spilt on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again; neither doth God respect any person: yet doth he devise means, that his banished be not expelled from him.*
>
> *— 2 Samuel 14:14*

And Lettie Brinson was standing in the yard.

She was forty miles away in West Palm Beach that evening, sitting in her kitchen chair, everybody at the church agreed on that afterward, and she was eighty years old and had not been out to the lake since the storm. But she was standing in the yard behind the church in Belle Glade, by the pump, where the third line of water had gone into the sand, in her old black hat. Sister Pinder saw her plain. The light was behind her, the long

gold light of evening that comes across the muck in summer, and it came through her a little, the way it comes through a curtain.

Now you see it, Lettie said. *You see it going. A body can live a hundred years and never once look at that. One day of looking at it is worth more. One evening like this one, daughter. Pray the Psalm.*

> *LORD, make me to know mine end, and the measure of my days, what it is: that I may know how frail I am.*
>
> *— Psalm 39:4*

Then there was nobody by the pump. There was the pump, and the yard, and the evening, and the dark of the bean fields beyond the church, and the long new dike against the sky.

Sister Pinder sat on the step. She did not get up for a long time. She watched the third line dry. It went from the far end first, the way they always do, back toward the step, until there was nothing to show where any of it had run. Then she set the pitcher down by her feet, and went in, and lit the lamp, because one of the girls from the bean camp was coming at dark, and would need to be told, gently, what the rules were, and why.

Background

The verses

> *Sons are no help, nor a father, nor relations; there is no help from kinsfolk for one whom death has seized.*
>
> Dhammapada 288, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *A wise and good man who knows the meaning of this, should quickly clear the way that leads to Nirvana.*
>
> Dhammapada 289, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *And he who lives a hundred years, not seeing beginning and end, a life of one day is better if a man sees beginning and end.*
>
> Dhammapada 113, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Paṭācārā is a rich merchant's daughter, kept on the top floor of her father's house, who runs away with a servant on the eve of an arranged marriage. Twice, near her time, she sets out for her parents' house to give birth. The first time her son is born by the road. The second time a storm out of season catches them. Her husband is killed by a snake while cutting brush for a shelter. At dawn a hawk carries off her newborn, and her older boy drowns in a swollen river. Then a traveler tells her that her parents and brother died in the same storm when their house fell, and points to the smoke of their pyre. She goes mad and wanders naked, pelted with dirt, until the Buddha says, "Sister, return to your right mind." He tells her that her tears over the dead are more than the four oceans and that kin are no refuge, and she becomes a nun. Years later, washing her feet, she watches spilled water run a short way, then farther, then farther yet, and sees in it death in youth, in middle age and in old age. The Buddha appears before her and speaks verse 113. She became the nun foremost in knowledge of the Discipline. Read the full commentary story, or about Paṭācārā.

Lake Okeechobee, Florida

Lake Okeechobee, 1928

By the 1920s, drainage canals and the Conners toll highway had opened the black muck south and east of Lake Okeechobee to farming. Towns like Belle Glade, Pahokee, South Bay, Canal Point and Chosen filled with Black farmworkers from Georgia, the Carolinas and the Bahamas, who picked beans and cut cane. On the night of September 16, 1928, the Okeechobee hurricane drove the lake over the low muck dike on its south shore and flooded hundreds of square miles, in places more than twenty feet deep. At least 2,500 people died, about three-quarters of them migrant farmworkers, most of them Black. The few coffins were kept for white victims. Many Black dead were burned on funeral pyres in the Glades. About 1,600 were buried in a mass grave at Port Mayaca, and 674 in a mass grave at Tamarind Avenue and 25th Street in West Palm Beach. That grave went unmarked until a state historical marker was placed in 2003 (see the Historical Society of Palm Beach County). Chosen never

recovered. Between 1932 and 1938 the Army Corps of Engineers built the dike that now rings the lake.

The African Methodist Episcopal Church began licensing women as lay preachers and evangelists in 1884 and created the office of deaconess in 1888. Women could not be ordained deacons until 1948 or elders until the 1950s and 1960s (see AME women preachers). Its rulebook, like that of other Methodist churches, is called the Discipline. Ozella, Lettie Brinson and their families are fictional, and so is the camp meeting of 1919.

After the story of Paṭācārā from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 113, 288 and 289). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.13

The Mustard Seed

For a day in thy courts is better than a thousand.
— Psalm 84:10

Così ho sentito dire, on the stoops below Washington Avenue.

I. Coal

South Philadelphia · 1912

Don Saverio Ferrante sold coal in the winter and ice in the summer out of a yard on Montrose Street, and between the two he had become the richest man from Washington Avenue to the Navy Yard. He had a brick house with a parlor nobody sat in and a piano nobody played. He kept some money in the bank on Christian Street and the rest of it under the floor of his bedroom, in a tin box, in gold, because he remembered what banks had done in Palermo.

One morning in March he lifted the board and opened the box, and the gold was coal.

Every piece. The double eagles were lumps of anthracite the size of walnuts. He ran to the bank in his shirtsleeves and made the teller open his deposit box, and that was coal too, and the teller stepped back from it as if it might catch. His wife's earrings, in the drawer by the bed, were two little black coals on gold wires. Then the gold wires were coal.

Don Saverio went to bed and did not get up. He lay there for nine days. The doctor came and left. The priest came and left. On the tenth day Mastro Pino the barber came and sat at the foot of the bed with his hat on his knee.

Saverio. Get up. Put all of it in the yard by the gate, in a pile, and sit by it like you're selling it.

Selling coal to who? I have a yard full of coal.

You're crazy already. The whole street says so. So be crazy where people can see you. Sometimes a saint walks by.

So Don Saverio put the coal that had been his gold in its own heap by the gate, apart from the other coal, and set a kitchen chair beside it and sat. People came by to laugh. *How much for the fancy coal, Don Saverio?* And he would say, *I only sell what's mine,* and they would go off shaking their heads.

Concetta Lo Bianco was sixteen. She lived with her mother in two back rooms on Kauffman Street, and she was so thin the whole neighborhood called her Sicca, the dry one, the stick. She came to the yard that afternoon with her mother's bucket and a nickel for coal. She stopped at the heap by the gate.

Don Saverio, she said, *why do you leave your gold out in the street like this? Somebody's going to take it.*

He looked at her for a long time.

Hand me some of my gold.

She put the bucket down and scooped up two handfuls and held them out to him, and what she put in his palms was gold. Double eagles, warm from the sun. Two earrings on gold wires. Everybody on Montrose Street who was watching stopped what they were doing, and some of them crossed themselves, and one of them dropped a crate of peppers.

Whose girl is this? said Don Saverio.

Within the year she married his son Nicola at St. Paul's, in a dress his mother sewed, and the old women said the gold had only been waiting for somebody who could see it.

II. The Wagon

October 1918

Tonino was born in the summer of 1916. He walked at eleven months and by two he was running the length of the coal yard with black on his knees, chasing the cat, and Don Saverio said he would be a runner in the Olympic Games, and Concetta, who was not called Sicca

ANYMORE, SAID HE WOULD BE A PRIEST, AND NICOLA SAID nothing because Nicola was in France.

The sickness came in off the ships at the Navy Yard in September. On the twenty-eighth there was a parade up Broad Street to sell Liberty Bonds, two miles of brass bands and soldiers and Boy Scouts, and two hundred thousand people stood on the sidewalks shoulder to shoulder to watch it. Ten days later the city had closed the schools and the churches and the saloons and the theaters, and it did not matter.

By the middle of October more than seven hundred people were dying in a single day. There were not enough coffins in Philadelphia. There were not enough gravediggers, so seminarians came down from Overbrook in their cassocks with shovels, and at Holy Cross they dug trenches with a steam shovel. On every street, doors had crepe on them. Black crepe for a grown person. Grey for an old one. White for a child.

Tonino woke with the fever on a Tuesday. On Thursday his lips went the color of a bruise. He died on Friday afternoon in her lap in the kitchen, with the window open, because the doctor, when there had still been a doctor, had said air.

Concetta had seen dead people. Everybody in the neighborhood had. She had sat up with her own grandmother and kissed her cold forehead in the box. But she had never seen death come into her own kitchen and take something that was hers, and she did not believe it. She would not believe it. It was a thing that happened on other streets.

On Saturday morning the wagon came down Montrose Street, a coal wagon with the coal shoveled out of it, and a young man with a rag over his face walked beside the horse calling out to the doors. Concetta closed hers.

She wrapped Tonino in his blue blanket and put him on her hip the way she carried him to the market and went out to find medicine.

Rossi's pharmacy had nothing on the shelves but a line out the door. She asked in the line. She asked the women on the stoops. She asked a policeman, and a man selling bananas, and the old women outside St. Paul's, which was locked. *Something for my son. He's sick. Something to make him better.* They looked at the blanket and they looked at her face, and

they stepped back. Mothers pulled children inside and shut the door. She heard somebody say it behind her, not even quietly. *Sicca's gone crazy.*

Mastro Pino was sitting in the doorway of his closed shop with a cloth soaked in camphor tied over his nose and mouth. He looked at the blanket for a long time, the way Don Saverio had looked at her six years before.

I don't have it, he said. *But there's a nun at the school on Ellsworth Street where they made the hospital. If anybody has the medicine, she has it.*

III. The Sister

The emergency hospital, Ellsworth Street

THEY HAD PUSHED THE SCHOOL DESKS INTO THE YARD AND filled the classrooms with cots, so that people lay coughing under blackboards with the alphabet still written along the top in perfect Palmer Method, capital and small, A to Z. Sister Benedicta was sixty-eight years old and had come from County Clare in a ship before the war with the South. She wore an apron over her habit and a gauze mask she kept pulling down so people could see her mouth.

She did not tell Concetta to put the child down. She did not tell her what she already knew. She lifted the corner of the blue blanket and looked at Tonino for a long time, and put the blanket back.

I know the medicine, she said. *You'll have to fetch it yourself. A pinch of mustard seed. Black or white, it doesn't matter.*

Concetta almost laughed. Everybody in Philadelphia had mustard that month. They were making mustard plasters in every kitchen in the city, smearing it on flannel and laying it on the chests of the sick.

But it has to come from a house where nobody has died, said Sister Benedicta. *Nobody, ever. Not a baby, not a grandmother. Not a boarder, not a cousin back in the old country. Nobody.*

Like the Gospel, Concetta said. *Faith like a mustard seed.*

Never mind the Gospel, said Sister Benedicta. *Go on.*

IV. The Doors

Saturday, all day

Mrs. Gallo across from the coal yard had black crepe on her door. She opened it with her sleeves pushed up and said of course, of course, and went to get the jar, and when Concetta asked, she stopped with the jar in her hand. Her husband. Tuesday. They took him on the same wagon.

The Dohertys on Federal Street had two crepes on the door, black and white, one above the other. Mrs. Doherty's apron was yellow to the elbow with mustard, because she was still making plasters for the three who were still in bed. *Love, you can have all the mustard in the world,* she said. *My Frank. My Mary Kate. She was four.*

On South Street, in the back of a dry goods store, the mirror was covered with a bedsheet and an old man sat on a low wooden box with his shirt torn at the collar. He had mustard seed in the crock where they made pickles. He said something in Yiddish and his granddaughter, nine years old, stood in the doorway and translated. *He says his wife. He says his brother. He says you should take the seed anyway.*

On Lombard Street Mrs. Tucker had brought mustard seed up from South Carolina in a Mason jar, to grow greens in a tub behind the house. *Lord, honey,* she said, and put her hand on Tonino's blanket as if he were sleeping. *My mother, back home, in July. My boy James on Wednesday. He worked at the Navy Yard.*

A Greek who sold fruit. A German baker's wife whose ovens were cold. A policeman's widow. Two sisters from Calabria who would not open the door but talked to her through it. A Chinese laundryman on Race Street who did not understand what she was asking for until she said *mustard* and pointed to her chest where the plaster goes, and then he understood, and went and got it, and then she asked the other thing, and he held up one finger, and then, slowly, a second.

Every house had the seed. No house had the other thing. She stopped counting the doors. She tried to count the dead instead, and lost count of

them too, and then something happened that she would never be able to explain to anybody, though she tried for sixty years.

It was somewhere around Ninth Street, in the late afternoon, in the long gold light that comes in October across the rooftops. The thing in her chest that had been closed like a fist since Friday opened. It did not break. It opened, slowly, the way a hand does when you stop telling it to hold on. She saw all the doors at once, all the crepe, black and white and grey, on every street in the city and every street in every city, back and back, Palermo and Clare and South Carolina and the place the laundryman came from and wherever it was the old man on South Street had come from, and none of it was hers alone and none of it had ever been. It was everybody's. It was the oldest thing there was.

She shifted Tonino to her other hip. He was heavy. He had been heavy all day, and she had not let herself feel it.

V. The Seed

Christian Street · evening

She found the wagon on Christian Street at dusk. The lamps had not been lit, because the men who lit them were sick or dead. The young man walking beside the horse was one of the seminarians from Overbrook, his cassock tucked up into his belt, his face grey with tiredness above the rag.

She stopped him with her hand on his arm.

This is Antonio Ferrante, she said. *He is two years and four months old. His father is Nicola Ferrante, of the 315th Infantry, in France. Will you write it down?*

He wrote it on a card with a pencil stub and pinned it to the blue blanket, and she kissed her son's forehead through the wool and gave him to the young man, who took him the way you take something from a person who is handing it to you, carefully, with both arms, and laid him in the wagon on the clean straw at the front, apart from the others. Then the young man made the sign of the cross over her, which he had no right to do yet, and she let him.

She walked back to Ellsworth Street with her arms empty. They felt light, and strange, and they kept rising a little at her sides, as if they had forgotten.

Sister Benedicta was at the sink in the teachers' room washing out basins.

Did you get the seed?

No, Sister. There isn't any. Concetta sat down on a child's chair. *In every house the dead are more than the living.*

Sister Benedicta dried her hands and sat down on the other little chair, knees up, two grown women at a school table, and said it to her very quietly, the way you'd tell somebody where the coats were kept.

> *Thou carriest them away as with a flood; they are as a sleep: in the morning they are like grass which groweth up. In the morning it flourisheth, and groweth up; in the evening it is cut down, and withereth.*
>
> *— Psalm 90:5–6*

Concetta sat for a long time. Then she asked if there was an apron.

There was.

• • •

The telegram came the week after the Armistice, when the bells were still ringing for the end of the war. Nicola had been killed below Montfaucon on the twenty-ninth of September, the day after the parade, two weeks before his son took sick. Concetta read it standing at the end of a row of cots, and folded it twice, and put it in her apron pocket, and went on taking temperatures. Don Saverio wept in the yard for a whole afternoon, sitting in the same kitchen chair by the gate, and she went and sat on the coal beside him until it got dark.

VI. The Lamp

The motherhouse chapel · 1921

She entered the Sisters in the spring of 1919. They let widows do that then, if the widow was serious, and nobody doubted she was serious. Sister Benedicta died the next winter, in the last hard wave of the sickness, on a cot in a ward she had been running the day before.

The new sisters took turns with the candles. Each night one of them went into the chapel after Compline and lit the votives in their red glasses on the iron stand, and trimmed the wicks, and sat with them for an hour so nothing would catch.

It was Concetta's turn on a night in February. She lit them one from another with a taper and sat in the back pew and watched.

One flame jumped up high and bright and then settled. One drowned in its own wax and went out with a thread of smoke. One leaned in a draft from under the door and righted itself. Two burned side by side, then one was gone. She watched them come up and go down, all of them, all along the rack, the way she had watched the doors on Ninth Street, and she understood that she was watching the same thing. Flames came and went. People came and went. Tonino. Nicola. Mrs. Doherty's Mary Kate. Sister Benedicta. Mrs. Tucker's James. Everybody had a flame, and the flames went out, and that was not the thing she was looking for.

The thing she was looking for was the light.

Not the flames. What the flames were in. It had been there before the first candle and it would be there after the last one and it had never once gone out, not in Palermo, not on Ninth Street, not in the coal yard on the day the gold turned black.

She did not hear the door. But she would say afterward, to the one person she ever told, that Sister Benedicta was standing just inside it, in her apron, with her mask pulled down so Concetta could see her mouth, and said it the way she said everything.

> *For a day in thy courts is better than a thousand. I had rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God, than to dwell in the tents of wickedness.*
>
> *— Psalm 84:10*

And then she was not there, and the candles burned, and Concetta Ferrante, whom they had called the stick, who had once put coal in a rich man's hands and seen it for what it was, sat in the back pew of the chapel until morning and saw.

• • •

She ran the clinic on Ellsworth Street for forty-one years. Young mothers came to her, all those years, carrying what they could not put down. She never sent any of them out for mustard seed. She sat with them on the little school chairs, knees up, and let them hold on as long as they needed to.

Then she told them it was very heavy. And that they could put it down when they were ready, and not one minute before.

Background

The verses

> *Death comes and carries off that man, praised for his children and flocks, his mind distracted, as a flood carries off a sleeping village.*
>
> Dhammapada 287, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *And he who lives a hundred years, not seeing the immortal place, a life of one day is better if a man sees the immortal place.*
>
> Dhammapada 114, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Kisā Gotamī ("Gotamī the thin") is a poor girl who turns a ruined merchant's charcoal back into gold and marries his son. When her small son dies, she carries his body from house to house looking for medicine, and the Buddha sends her for a mustard seed from a house where no one has died. Years later, as a nun, she reaches awakening watching lamp flames rise and go out. Read the full commentary story, or about Kisā Gotamī.

South Philadelphia

Philadelphia, 1918

The influenza reached Philadelphia through the Navy Yard in September 1918. On September 28 the city went ahead with the Fourth Liberty Loan parade down Broad Street, and some 200,000 people packed the sidewalks to watch. Within days the hospitals were full. On October 3 the city closed its schools, churches and theaters. On the worst day in October more than 750 people died, and by the end of the epidemic about 12,000 Philadelphians were dead. Coffins ran out, seminarians helped dig graves, and at Holy Cross Cemetery trenches were dug by steam shovel. Families hung crepe on the door: black for an adult, white for a child, grey for the old. More on the 1918 pandemic.

Nicola's regiment, the 315th Infantry, belonged to the 79th Division, made up largely of draftees from Philadelphia and the surrounding region. In the opening days of the Meuse-Argonne offensive at the end of September, the division attacked the heights of Montfaucon and took heavy losses.

After the story of Kisā Gotamī from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 114 and 287). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

8.14

Tree Prayer

> *I had heard of thee by the hearing of the ear; But now mine eye seeth thee.*
> *— Job 42:5*

Ireoke deureosseoyo, on Pleasant Hill Road.

I. The Store

Candler Road, DeKalb County · 2013

For thirty-four years Shin Jeong-ok pressed other people's clothes. She ran Sunrise Cleaners on Candler Road with her husband, Lee Man-sik, in a strip of stores between a check-cashing place and a barbershop, and she could look at a stain on a blouse and tell you whether it was coffee or red clay or blood, and how old it was, and whether it would come out. Man-sik worked the register and the boiler and the long conveyor of plastic bags that went round the ceiling and came back down when you pushed the button. She worked the steam press and the Singer in the back. She let out the waists of church pants and took up the hems of prom dresses, and fixed zippers for a dollar, and pinned a paper ticket to every collar with a safety pin, and she was nearly never wrong about anything that came across the counter.

The women called her Miss Shin, or Mama Shin, or just Mama. Some of them had been coming since they were girls, holding their mothers' hands. Miss Loretta Pugh, who was on the usher board at Greater Mount Calvary, had brought in the same white usher's dress every Monday morning since 1986, and every Monday Jeong-ok had it back on the rack by Wednesday with the collar starched the way Loretta liked it, and Lor-

etta's ticket pinned on the left side, where the heart is, because Loretta had asked her to once and she had never forgotten.

She had seven children. Four sons and three daughters, five born in Seoul and two at Grady Hospital, and every one of them had done homework on an upturned milk crate in the back of the store under a calendar from the Korean bank on Buford Highway. Every one of them had gone to college. Every one of them was married now, to a Korean or near enough, and lived in a house in Gwinnett or north Fulton with a basement and a two-car garage and a mailbox at the end of the drive, and on Sundays most of them sat in the same Full Gospel church in Duluth where their parents had sat since the church met in a rented Baptist fellowship hall.

Man-sik died in March, at four in the morning, in the car in the church parking lot, waiting for dawn prayer to start. He had the engine running for the heat. The deacon who found him said he looked like a man who had come early and dozed off, which was true.

The funeral took three days. The children took turns at the guest book and at the door. On the fourth day Jeong-ok put on her black cardigan and drove to Candler Road and lifted the steel gate and opened the store, because it was a Monday and there would be dresses.

Loretta Pugh came in at nine with the white dress over her arm and stood at the counter a long time. Then she came around the end of it, which no customer did, and held Jeong-ok against her chest without saying anything, and Jeong-ok let herself be held, and smelled Loretta's perfume, which was the same perfume she had worn since 1986 too.

II. Seven Envelopes

Duluth · summer and fall, 2013

The sons brought it up at the kitchen table in the house on the cul-de-sac in Duluth, one Sunday in June after church, while the daughters and the daughters-in-law washed the dishes and pretended not to listen.

Daniel, the eldest, said it. He was a pharmacist and he said things in the order a pharmacist says them, gently and in a row. *Umma. Abba is gone now. What do you need the store for? You're seventy-three. You stand all day on that concrete. There's no one to watch the door. We can take care of you. Isn't that what we're for?*

She listened, and said nothing, and got up and brought the fruit.

They said it again on Chuseok in September, and again at Samuel's daughter's first birthday, and again on the phone, one son and then another, so that she could tell they had talked about it among themselves. She said nothing each time. But at night in the house on the cul-de-sac, which was too large now and made sounds she did not remember it making, she thought about her husband in the car with the engine running, and about her own knees, and about her four sons, who were good boys, who had been good boys always, who had done their homework on a milk crate.

My sons will look after me, she thought. *Why should I hold onto anything for myself?*

She sold the store in October to Tonya Gaines, who had worked the counter beside her for eleven years and knew every customer's name and every customer's starch, and who got a loan from a small business program and a smaller one from her church. Jeong-ok sold it to her for less than the machines were worth and left her the Singer. She sold the house in Duluth in November to a young couple from Busan with a baby. In December she sat at the kitchen table of an apartment she had rented by the month, with a lawyer from church across from her, and signed what he put in front of her, and the lawyer handed her seven envelopes, and she wrote a name on each one in her careful hand, in Korean and in English, eldest to youngest.

She kept one suitcase of clothes, her Bible, her husband's reading glasses, and the earthenware crock she had carried from Seoul in 1977 with her own soybean paste in it, which she had kept going ever since, adding the new year's paste to the old every spring, for thirty-six years.

III. The Guest Rooms

Suwanee, Johns Creek, Lawrenceville · 2014

Daniel's house was in a subdivision in Suwanee called Ashford Glen, with a pool and tennis courts and a stone sign at the entrance with water running down it. Jeong-ok had the guest room over the garage. Her daughter-in-law Jenny had put fresh towels on the bed in a fan shape, and a bottle of water on the nightstand, as if for a hotel.

The first week was good. Jeong-ok cooked. She made doenjang stew with the paste from her crock, and fried anchovies with sesame and honey, and sat with her granddaughters while they did their homework and did not understand a word of it. The second week Jenny began to open the kitchen windows when Jeong-ok cooked, and to turn on the vent fan, and once, after the fish, to walk through the downstairs with a can of air freshener that smelled like an apple that had never grown on any tree. The third week the crock went out to the garage, beside the second refrigerator and the girls' bicycles, because of the smell.

On a Thursday at the end of the month Jeong-ok came down the back stairs to the laundry room for a dish towel and stopped, because Jenny was in there on the phone with her sister in Marietta, in English, folding sheets.

Apparently ours is the only house in Georgia she knows how to find, Jenny said. *You'd think she gave the whole store to Daniel. He got one envelope. Same as everybody.*

Jeong-ok went back up the stairs without the towel. She had run a cleaners on Candler Road for thirty-four years. She had argued with the chemical suppliers in English, and with the alarm company, and with a man from the county about the sign. She had stood behind that counter through two robberies and a tornado warning and the morning a man came in to tell her, in English, at length, to go back where she came from. She understood English very well. Her children had always forgotten that, and spoken in front of her in it as if it were a room she could not get into.

In March she moved to Samuel's in Johns Creek. Samuel's wife Hannah was kind and very busy and set her up in the room where the treadmill was. In May, Hannah said it too, to Samuel, in their bedroom with the door not quite closed. *Is this the only house she can go to? You'd think the store went to the second son.* In July Jeong-ok went to Joseph's in Lawrenceville, where the guest room was the baby's room and the baby slept with his parents while she was there, and cried, and the crying came through the wall, and on the fourth night Joseph's wife Michelle asked her, very politely, whether she could pray more quietly in the mornings. Jeong-ok had prayed aloud at five o'clock every morning of her life since she was twelve years old, the way her mother had and her grandmother in Pyongyang before her. She prayed in a whisper after that. She found she did not know how. In August Michelle said it. In September Peter's wife said it, in the car, to Peter, while Jeong-ok sat in the back seat with the grandson's car seat between them.

Then the daughters. Grace in Alpharetta, the eldest daughter, who had been a girl at the milk crate and was now a woman with a nice kitchen and a cleaning lady on Tuesdays. *Umma, you're always here. Don't the boys have rooms?* Esther, who lived nearest, in Peachtree Corners, and was the gentlest of them all. *Umma, I love you, but Kevin's mother is coming in November, and you know how Kevin's mother is.* And Ruth, the youngest, the one born at Grady, who had once wept at the sight of an injured squirrel, and who said it on the phone without knowing her mother had already said goodbye to her husband and was standing behind her at the door with the suitcase.

Seven houses. Seven guest rooms. Fresh towels in seven fan shapes, and a bottle of water on each nightstand. Jeong-ok sat on the edge of the bed in Ruth's guest room in October with her hands in her lap and looked at the bottle of water for a long time.

Then she thought: *Why should I keep living like this? I will go up the mountain.*

IV. The Mountain

Gilmer County, in the north Georgia mountains · autumn 2014

The prayer mountain was an old Baptist youth camp the church had bought in 1988, two hours north of the city, past the apple orchards and the roadside stands selling fried pies, up a gravel road with a cable across it and a hand-lettered sign in two languages. There was a chapel with a tin roof and a long porch on cedar posts. There was a dining hall and two dormitories and a bathhouse. Up the ridge behind the chapel, through the white pines, there were thirty little prayer rooms the size of a closet, each one with a door and a window and a cushion and a Bible and a box of tissues, and at the very top of the ridge there was a white cross twenty feet tall that had a ring of electric bulbs on it and could be seen at night from the state highway.

Jeong-ok had come up on Friday nights for twenty years in the church van with the other women, to pray all night in the chapel and walk the ridge in the dark and come down at dawn with their voices gone. She had never come up alone. She had never come on a Tuesday.

Choi Moksa-nim, who had founded the place and had been its pastor for twenty-six years, was eighty-four. He lived in a two-room house at the bottom of the hill, by the gate, with a woodstove and a cat. He was small and bald and wore the same grey cardigan in all weather, and in all those Friday nights Jeong-ok had never heard him preach for more than ten minutes, or raise his voice once. He did not ask her about her children. He did not ask her about the store, or the money, or why she had come up the mountain on a Tuesday afternoon in October in a taxi from Ellijay with one suitcase and a crock.

He looked at her for a while on the porch of his house, the way she used to look at a woman holding up a picture out of a magazine.

There's a bed in the women's dormitory, he said. *Deaconess Bae will show you the kitchen.*

Three women lived on the mountain the year round. Deaconess Bae, who had never married and ran the kitchen like a ship. Mrs. Kwon, a widow from Chicago, who had come up for one weekend in 2009 and not

gone back. And now Jeong-ok. They cooked for the retreats on weekends, rice for two hundred in the big steel pots. They cleaned the prayer rooms on Mondays, emptied the wastebaskets of tissues and shook out the cushions. They swept pine needles off the chapel porch that came back the next morning. They prayed at five in the chapel with Pastor Choi, and at noon, and in the evening, and whenever else they liked, and nobody on the mountain had ever asked anybody else to pray more quietly.

The first week, Jeong-ok drove down to Ellijay with Mrs. Kwon and went into a salon off the square and had her hair cut short, very short, close to the head like an old man's. For thirty-four years she had worn it long and pinned up out of the steam. She watched it fall onto the cape and onto the floor, grey and black, and the girl with the scissors asked if she was sure, and she said she was sure, and gave her a ten-dollar tip.

She turned off her phone and put it in her suitcase. Her daughters had sent her sermons on KakaoTalk, links to pastors in Seoul and Dallas and Los Angeles who preached for an hour on prosperity and on the end of the world. She did not watch them anymore. On the mountain she took what Pastor Choi gave. He gave out one verse on Sunday, written on a card in his small square hand, and she carried that one verse all week in her apron pocket and took it out and looked at it in the dish water and on the ridge and in the dark, and turned it over, and did not ask for another.

V. The Posts and the Trees

The ridge · winter

I CAME LATE, SHE THOUGHT. *I CAME TO THIS AT SEVENTY-FOUR years old, when the others came at forty. I can't afford to sleep.*

So she began to pray through the nights. She would help Deaconess Bae with the supper dishes and put on her coat and her husband's wool hat and go out to the chapel porch while the others went to bed. She prayed on the porch first. The light over the chapel door had burned out in November and nobody had gotten up on the ladder, and her eyes were not good anymore in the dark, cataracts in both, which the doctor in Duluth had wanted to fix and which she had put off for the store and then

for the funeral and then for everything else. So she walked the length of the porch with her hand on the cedar posts. Post to post. Twelve posts down and twelve posts back, her palm on each one as she came to it, praying under her breath, turning the verse in her apron pocket over in her mind the way you turn a stone over in your fingers.

When the porch was not enough she went up the ridge.

There were no lights on the ridge path. There had never been. Pastor Choi had refused them for twenty-six years, against every committee and building fund in the church. People could come up a mountain in the dark, he said. People had done it for a very long time. The only light was the ring of bulbs on the cross at the top, which was far away and showed you where you were going without showing you anything at all about how to get there.

The first week she struck her head on a low pine bough and had a bruise above her eye that went from purple to green to yellow, and Deaconess Bae looked at it at breakfast and said nothing and put an extra egg on her rice.

After that she went up the ridge the way she had walked the porch. She put her hand out in the dark and found a tree, and held it, and stood there and prayed, and then let it go and put her hand out for the next one. Tree to tree. White pines mostly, and a few hemlocks, and one big oak at the switchback that she came to know by the feel of it, as rough as a cinderblock wall. Her palms got sticky with pitch. Her husband's hat caught on twigs. She went up in the dark tree by tree and came down in the dark tree by tree, and somewhere around three in the morning she would sit in one of the little prayer rooms with the door open and the cold coming in, and the stars over the ridge so many and so near that she could make no sense of them, and then she would go up again.

She had done this once before in her life. She had not thought of it in fifty years. In December of 1950, when she was ten, her family had walked south out of Pyongyang with everything they could carry, ahead of the Chinese armies, on frozen roads, with thousands upon thousands of other families, mostly at night. She had walked the whole way holding the hem of her mother's coat in her fist so as not to lose her in the dark.

When her mother stopped, she stopped. When her mother went on, she went on. She had not let go once in eleven nights. She remembered now, on the ridge, the exact feel of that wool in her hand.

The tips of her fingers went black with pitch and stayed that way. She did not try to wash it off. It did not hurt anything.

VI. The Light

The bench below the cross · January 2015

In the second week of January Pastor Choi had pneumonia, and Deaconess Bae drove him down the mountain to the hospital in Jasper, and stayed with him there. That left Mrs. Kwon and Jeong-ok alone on the mountain. It snowed a little on the Thursday and froze on the Friday, and nobody came up from the city for the all-night prayer, because the gravel road was ice.

Jeong-ok went up the ridge on Friday night anyway, tree to tree, with frozen pine needles cracking under her shoes. It was very cold. Her breath went out ahead of her and she could not see it go. Near the top, below the cross, there was a wooden bench where people sat to catch their breath, and a white pine beside it, and she had her hand on that pine and her forehead against the back of her hand when she saw the light coming up the path behind her.

She thought at first that it was Mrs. Kwon with a flashlight. Then she thought it was a car, because it was too wide and too soft for a flashlight, and she wondered how anybody could have gotten a car up the ridge. Then it was on the bench beside her, and it was Pastor Choi.

He was sitting on the bench in his grey cardigan with no coat and no hat, with his hands on his knees, the way he sat in the chapel on Friday nights before he got up to speak his ten minutes. He was not shivering. The light was coming off him, or was all around him, or both. It was the color of the light in a kitchen very early in the morning when somebody else is already up. She could see the bark of the pine under her own hand in it, every ridge, and the black pitch on her fingers, and her breath. She

could see his face very clearly, close to hers, nearer than she had ever been to it, as close as a person you are talking with across a small table.

She was not afraid. She would say afterward that she had expected to be and had not been, and that she did not know why.

Shin Kwonsa, he said. *You have been walking a long way to see something.*

Yes, Moksa-nim.

People live eighty years, ninety years. A hundred. They raise children and the children raise children and they buy the house and sell the house, and they never once look up and see. One day seeing is better than that. One hour. Do you understand me?

She said she was trying to.

He said it to her then from the book of the Preacher, which she had read a hundred times and had never once read, quietly, the way you would tell somebody where you had put their glasses.

> *If a man beget a hundred children, and live many years, so that the days of his years are many, but his soul be not filled with good, and moreover he have no burial; I say, that an untimely birth is better than he.*
>
> *Yea, though he live a thousand years twice told, and yet enjoy no good, do not all go to one place?*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 6:3, 6*

Then she saw.

She would never be able to say it better than that, though Mrs. Kwon asked her, and later her daughters asked her, and once a young pastor from Atlanta with a notebook. It was as if she had been walking all her life with her hand out in the dark, from tree to tree and post to post and coat hem to coat hem, from Pyongyang to Seoul to Candler Road to the seven guest rooms, holding on to the next thing so as not to strike her head, and for one moment somebody had turned on the light, and she saw that the path had been there all along, and the trees, and the cross, and the whole ridge, and that she had been on it the whole time. Her husband in the car with the engine running. Loretta Pugh at the counter.

Jenny folding sheets. Her mother's coat. Her own hand on the pine. None of it was in the dark. None of it ever had been. She looked at all of it at once and nothing was missing.

She heard herself say it aloud, in the old way, the way she had prayed every morning of her life until Lawrenceville.

> *I had heard of thee by the hearing of the ear; But now mine eye seeth thee.*
>
> *— Job 42:5*

Then the bench was empty, and it was dark, and the ring of bulbs hummed on the cross above her in the cold.

• • •

Mrs. Kwon had seen the light from the dormitory window, at a quarter past two. She said it was too high on the ridge to be a car and too wide to be a flashlight and too yellow to be the cross, and that it stayed for about as long as it takes to say the Lord's Prayer twice, slowly, and that she had said it twice to find out.

Deaconess Bae called from the hospital in Jasper at seven in the morning to say the fever had broken in the night. The nurse on the floor told her that the old man had slept the whole night through with the oxygen on, and that around two he had talked a little in his sleep, in Korean, very calmly, the way a person talks across a table. When Deaconess Bae asked him about it later, he said he did not remember dreaming, and asked whether the women had remembered to put salt down on the chapel steps.

VII. The Bark

Chuseok · September 2015

THEY CAME UP THE MOUNTAIN ON THE HOLIDAY IN FOUR CARS, all seven of them, with their husbands and their wives and their children, because Esther had called the dining hall and Deaconess Bae had told

HER THAT HER MOTHER WAS WELL, AND HAD TOLD HER NOTHing else, and Esther had not been able to sleep. They brought half-moon rice cakes in plastic trays from the Korean bakery on Pleasant Hill Road, and a box of Asian pears, and a bottle of the good sesame oil.

They found their mother on the chapel porch with a broom, sweeping off the pine needles that would be back by morning. Her hair was short and white. Her fingertips were black. She looked at them coming up the gravel from the cars, all of them at once, and set down the broom, and the children said afterward, each in his own way and her own way, that they had never been looked at like that by anyone. Grace started to cry before she reached the steps and could not have said why.

Jeong-ok fed them. She went into the dining hall kitchen with Deaconess Bae and came out with rice and soup and nine kinds of side dishes, and the soup was made from the paste in the crock she had brought from Seoul in 1977. Jenny ate two bowls of it and asked for the recipe. Jeong-ok told her, and Jenny wrote it down on her phone.

After dinner the grown children sat on the porch with Pastor Choi and talked in low voices, about what should be done, about whether their mother should come home, and to whose home. Jeong-ok did the dishes. Nobody asked her to pray more quietly, and she did not.

Ruth's daughter Abigail was eight. She was bored with the grown-ups, and she went up the ridge path by herself in the last of the evening light to see the big cross. Halfway up, she stopped and looked at a pine tree beside the path. There was a dark, smooth place on the bark at the height of her own forehead, about the size of a hand, worn and polished and black with pitch, as if somebody had touched it in the same spot every night for a year. She looked at the next tree up the path. It had one too. So did the next, and the next, and the big oak at the switchback, all the way up the ridge to the bench below the cross, one dark hand-shaped place on every tree, at the height of an old woman's shoulder.

Abigail reached up and put her own small hand flat on the first one. It was warm from the day. When she took it away her palm was sticky, and it smelled like the inside of the woods, and she did not wipe it on her dress.

Background

The verse

> *And he who lives a hundred years, not seeing the highest law, a life of one day is better if a man sees the highest law.*
>
> Dhammapada 115, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a devout widow of Sāvatthī with seven sons and seven daughters keeps her husband's estate until her children ask why she needs it when they could support her. She divides it among them, and soon every daughter-in-law and every daughter complains that hers is the only house the old woman visits. She leaves them and is ordained as a nun, and because she has come to the life so late she resolves to meditate all night, guiding herself in the dark with a hand on the pillars and then on the trees so as not to strike her head. The Buddha, seated in his own chamber at Jetavana, sends a radiant image of himself to sit face to face with her and speaks the verse, and she is awakened. Read the full commentary story.

Duluth and Gilmer County, Georgia

Korean Atlanta, 2013–2015

The Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 ended the national-origins quotas that had shut out most Asian immigrants, and Korean families began arriving in large numbers in the following decades. Between 1990 and 2000 Georgia had the fastest-growing Korean community in the country. In metro Atlanta, Korean grocers, restaurants and shops first clustered along Buford Highway in Doraville in the 1980s, then moved north into Gwinnett County, where Duluth now has the largest Koreatown in the Southeast.

Between 60 and 65 percent of Korean Americans identify as Christian, and there are some four thousand Korean churches in the United States. Many of those families trace their faith to the north of the peninsula, where Korean Christianity was

strongest before the war; many northern Christians fled south in 1950 and after. Korean churches carried over a tradition of fervent prayer: daily prayer meetings before dawn, Friday all-night vigils, and the prayer mountain, or *kidowon*, a retreat where believers pray outdoors through the night, sometimes holding onto trees as a sign of their devotion.

After the story of Bahuputtikā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 115). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 9

Evil

9.1

One Shawl

> *For behold, this life is the time for men to prepare to meet God; yea, behold the day of this life is the day for men to perform their labors.*
> — *Alma 34:32*

Fel hyn y clywais i, in Great Salt Lake City.

I. The Shawl

Great Salt Lake City · 1849–1856

Ifan and Gwen Pugh came to the valley in the autumn of 1849 with the Welsh, three hundred of them, who had sailed out of Liverpool singing and gone up the Mississippi in a steamboat and walked from the Missouri River to the mountains. In Merthyr Ifan had cut coal. In the valley there was no coal anybody had found yet, so he cut stone. He quarried it and hauled it and squared it for the public works, and for the foundation of the Temple when they started on it, and he was paid at the tithing office in flour and potatoes and squash and paper scrip, and he and Gwen did well enough for six years. They had an adobe house of two rooms with a dirt roof, and a clock, and a feather bed, and a Book of Mormon in Welsh that had come over in a later ship, and each of them had a good coat.

Then the grasshoppers came in the summer of 1855. They came out of the ground where they had been laid the fall before and ate the wheat as it sprouted. They ate the corn. They ate the squash vines down to the roots. Women threw shawls and bedsheets over their gardens to save something, and the grasshoppers ate the shawls. Gwen would not put hers out. She sat on the step all one week in August with a broom and

beat them off the squash by hand, and saved four squash, and the neighbors laughed at her and then came to ask for seed.

There had been hardly any snow the winter before, and there was no rain that summer. The canyons burned. The oxen that hauled the stone for the Temple had nothing to eat, and the work on the Temple stopped, and Ifan's work stopped with it. That winter a third of the cattle in the valley died in the cold. The Pughs ate the four squash and then sold the clock for flour. Then Ifan's good coat. Then the feather bed and both blankets and Gwen's second dress and her coat. In the spring of 1856 Gwen went up on the bench with a digging stick for sego roots, the way she had heard the first settlers did in the cricket years, and boiled pigweed, and they lived.

By that autumn they owned what they stood in, and one shawl.

It was grey Welsh flannel with a red stripe along the border, and Gwen's mother had woven it in Llanidloes and given it to her at the dock in Liverpool, and it was the warmest thing either of them had ever owned. Whoever had to go out wore it. Whoever stayed home stayed by the fire. It was a woman's shawl, but men wore shawls that year, the way they wore anything; Ifan wore it crossed on his chest and tied behind, and nobody on their street said anything about it, because half the men there had something of their wives' on.

In September the home missionaries came. That was the year of the Reformation, when the whole church was called to repent and be baptized over again, and every ward had two men who went house to house and sat at every table and asked every family the questions. Do you pray in your family night and morning. Do you speak against your brethren. Do you pay your tithing promptly. The two who came to the Pughs were a hatter and a young clerk. They sat at Ifan's table, which was a plank on two trestles, under the dirt roof, and Ifan answered every question the way it ought to be answered except the one about tithing. The clerk wrote it in the book. Ifan said that if he had anything he would give a tenth of it, and the hatter said he knew that, and the clerk wrote that down too.

II. Sunday

October 5, 1856

It was conference. The word had gone around the night before that Brother Franklin Richards had come in from the States with bad news, but nobody in the Welsh houses knew what it was.

Morning or afternoon? Ifan said, because they could not both go.

Morning, said Gwen, and put on the shawl, and went.

She came back after noon without her stockings. She sat down on the stool by the fire and held out her bare white ankles in her shoes and told him why.

There were people on the plains, she said. Hundreds of them. Two companies with handcarts, from the old countries, who had started too late in the year from the Missouri, and they were somewhere out on the Platte now with winter coming, and nobody in the valley had known they were coming at all. Brother Richards had passed them on the road. President Young had stood up and said they must be brought in, and help must be sent to them now, and he wanted teams and flour and teamsters, and that the faith of anybody who sat in their seat and did nothing would be in vain. And then the sisters had started to take things off. Right there in the Tabernacle. Petticoats. Stockings. Their shawls. A woman in front of Gwen had given her shoes and walked out barefoot in October. They piled it all in the aisles and men carried it out in armfuls to the wagons.

So I gave my stockings, Gwen said. *They were mine.*

She did not say anything about the shawl. She took it off and folded it and hung it on its peg by the door, and Ifan understood that she had worn it home because it was not only hers to give.

The bishop had sent word around that there would be a meeting in the ward schoolhouse that evening, and that whatever anybody had was to be brought to his yard, because the wagons were going east at first light on Tuesday and every ward was to fill its share. Ifan put on the shawl at dusk, crossed and tied behind, and went.

III. The Watches

The bishop's yard · Sunday night

Bishop Ezra Tuttle was seventy-four years old and a shoemaker. He had come from Vermont to Kirtland and from Kirtland to Missouri and from Missouri to Nauvoo and from Nauvoo across Iowa in the mud, and he had buried his wife at Winter Quarters, and he still had the same awl. He lived alone in the back of his shop on a cot. He was not a speaker. People who had been in his ward for five years would tell you they had never heard him say more than a hundred words at a meeting, and most of those were the names of the sick.

At the schoolhouse that night he stood up and read out what the President had asked for, in the President's own words, off a paper. Then he opened his Book of Mormon and read one verse. Then he sat down.

> *And now behold, my beloved brethren, I say unto you, do not suppose that this is all; for after ye have done all these things, if ye turn away the needy, and the naked, and visit not the sick and afflicted, and impart of your substance, if ye have, to those who stand in need—I say unto you, if ye do not any of these things, behold, your prayer is vain, and availeth you nothing, and ye are as hypocrites who do deny the faith.*
>
> *— Alma 34:28*

Ifan sat on the back bench in the shawl. The word that went into him was *naked.* He felt the shawl on his shoulders the way you feel a hand.

The bishop went home after the meeting and built a fire in his yard and sat down beside it on a box with his ledger on his knees, and people brought things. They brought them all night. Two wagons stood in the yard with their tongues down, and men loaded them by lantern light, and the bishop wrote down every gift in the ledger in a slow square hand, the name and the thing. Flour, a sack. Quilts, two. Boots, one pair, mended. Stockings. A buffalo robe with the hair half gone. A side of bacon from somebody who must have been hiding it since spring. Ifan came into the

yard and sat down on the ground at the edge of the firelight, near the bishop's feet, with the shawl around him, and did not get up.

He watched them come. A widow from the next street brought her dead husband's boots and stood them side by side at the bishop's feet, as if he might still step into them, and went home without a word. Two boys brought a crock of molasses between them, carrying it like a coffin. The hatter who had sat at Ifan's table in September brought three hats, which made the men at the wagons laugh, and then they stopped laughing and loaded them, because a hat is a hat on the Sweetwater in November. Somebody brought a child's red mittens. The bishop wrote them down. Mittens, one pair, red.

He was going to give it. He had known on the bench in the schoolhouse that he was going to give it. Then he thought of Gwen, at home by a fire with no wood to spare for it, in a dress and no stockings, and the winter coming, and the two of them with nothing between them and January, and no way for either one to go out of the door. He thought of the dock at Liverpool, and Gwen's mother putting the shawl around Gwen's shoulders with her own two hands and then looking past her at Ifan, not at Gwen, and saying to him in Welsh, *Keep her warm.* He thought of the squash on the step in August and Gwen with the broom. He thought: there are wards in this city with rich men in them. Let the rich men give. He thought: it is only one shawl, what is one shawl to hundreds of people. He thought of a thousand things, each one sensible, each one a little colder than the one before. And in between them, every so often, one other thought, very small and very clear, that said, *Give it.* And every time it came, the thousand sensible things came in after it and took it by the arms and put it out.

The bishop's clock struck ten in the shop behind him. Ifan sat. The clock struck midnight. People stopped coming. The men loading the wagons went home to sleep for three hours. The bishop put more wood on the fire and sat on his box and wrote nothing, because there was nothing to write, and did not look at Ifan at all. The stars went over. The Big Dipper turned on its handle above the mountains. The clock struck two.

The clock struck three. Ifan thought, very clearly: two watches of the night are gone while I have been sitting here fighting. If this goes on, these sensible thoughts will grow, and grow, and they will hold me down for the rest of my life, and I will never get my head up out of them.

Before the clock struck four he got up on his feet. He untied the knot at his back. He took the shawl off, and the cold went into his chest like water, and he laid it down at the bishop's feet, on the ground, folded. And then he did a thing he had not known he was going to do. He put his head back and shouted it out into the yard, in Welsh, three times, loud enough to wake the street, the word for when you have won a fight.

Gorchfygais! Gorchfygais! Gorchfygais!

IV. Blankets

Monday, before dawn

Hiram Bostwick had come up the street with his flour wagons a few minutes before. He had come into the valley with the first freighting trains, and he owned the biggest store on East Temple Street and a house with glass in every window, and he was bringing twenty sacks of flour to the bishop's yard himself, because he was a man who liked to be seen to do a thing and also liked to do it. He was standing at the gate in a buffalo coat when the shouting started.

What was that? Ask him what he's won.

His clerk went over and asked. Ifan told him, in English, plainly, standing in his shirt at the fire. One shawl, between the two of them. His wife had gone to the morning meeting in it and he had come to the evening. He had sat there since nine o'clock trying to give it. He had won.

Bostwick stood a while at the gate. *That's a hard thing,* he said. *That's a harder thing than mine.* And he sent the clerk across to his store, and the clerk came back with a pair of blankets, good white Mackinaw blankets with a black stripe, and gave them to Ifan.

Ifan looked at them and laid them on the shawl at the bishop's feet.

Bostwick sent the clerk back for two pairs. Ifan laid them on the pile. Four pairs. He laid them down. Eight. The clerk was running now, and

two of the bishop's neighbors had come out in their nightshirts to see what the shouting was, and stayed to carry. Sixteen pairs. Ifan laid them all on the pile without so much as unfolding them, and the bishop wrote each one in the ledger, Blankets, two pair, I. Pugh, Blankets, four pair, I. Pugh, without a word.

When the clerk came back with thirty-two pairs on a handcart from the store, Bostwick stopped him at the gate.

Brother Pugh, he said, *you keep one pair of these for yourself, and you give one pair to your wife. I won't have it said in this city that I let a man freeze to death in front of me for the sake of being generous.* So Ifan kept two pairs, and thirty pairs went into the wagons.

Then Bostwick sent the clerk to his house, and the clerk came back with two buffalo robes over his shoulder, the two best robes in the territory, people said afterward, winter robes with the hair thick and dark and soft as a cat, tanned by Shoshone women up on the Bear River and painted on the skin side with red and yellow lines. Bostwick put them in Ifan's arms himself.

Ifan stood holding them. He thought: I am not fit to wrap myself in this. This was not given to me. He walked into the back of the bishop's shop, where the old man had slept alone on a cot for nine years under a dirt roof that came down in mud on him every time it rained, and he took the bishop's hammer and the bishop's tacks and nailed the first robe flat to the rafters over the cot, hair side down, so that when it rained the bishop would sleep dry under a buffalo for the rest of his life.

The other he carried home to Gwen, along with the two pairs of blankets, at first light. She was asleep by the cold fire in her dress. He did not wake her. He nailed the second robe to the rafters over the plank table, where the home missionaries had sat in September and the roof had dribbled dirt on the young clerk's ledger, so that whoever came to that table to ask the questions next time would sit in a dry place. Then he put both pairs of blankets over his wife and lay down on the floor beside her and slept until noon.

On Tuesday morning the wagons went east out of the city, sixteen of them from all the wards together, with four mules to a wagon and young

men walking beside, and half the city out in the cold to watch them go up toward the mouth of Emigration Canyon. Somewhere in one of them, under thirty pairs of Mackinaw blankets and a widow's boots and three hats and a child's red mittens, there was a grey flannel shawl with a red stripe, folded in four. Gwen did not go to watch. She said she had seen wagons.

V. Fours

Tuesday and after

Bostwick came to the bishop's shop on Tuesday evening to settle a bill for boots, and he saw the robe nailed over the cot in the back room, and knew it.

Bishop, who gave you that?

Brother Pugh, said the bishop.

Bostwick stood looking at it for some time. Then he said that a man likes to think he is the only one in the city who believes a thing all the way down, and it does him good to find out he isn't. And the next day there came to the Pughs' door, from Bostwick, four oxen, and four horses, and four sacks of flour, and four hundred dollars in gold in a canvas bag, and his claim to four acres of bottom land along the Jordan with water on it.

The ward talked of nothing else for a week. At the meeting on Thursday night, before the bishop came in, they were still at it on the benches. The Lord had paid Ifan Pugh before the wagons were out of sight. He had given one shawl at four in the morning and been paid in oxen by Wednesday. There it was, plain as day, cause and effect, and the Reformation was right, and the Book was right, and you only had to give.

The bishop came in and sat down at the table in front and asked them what they were all talking about. They told him.

He thought about it. Then he said, in the most words anybody in that ward ever heard him say at once:

Brother Pugh brought it at four in the morning, and he got fours. If he'd brought it in from his seat at the meeting Sunday night, I expect he'd have got eights. If he'd stood up in the Tabernacle Sunday noon and given it when his

wife gave her stockings, sixteens. What comes back to you is a measure. It comes back about the size you let it out. When the good thing comes up in you, do it. Do it while it's still up. Don't sit in the yard all night with it. The other thing will grow in the dark and sit on you, and you'll get to like it there.

Then he opened the Book and read.

> *For behold, this life is the time for men to prepare to meet God; yea, behold the day of this life is the day for men to perform their labors.*
>
> *And now, as I said unto you before, as ye have had so many witnesses, therefore, I beseech of you that ye do not procrastinate the day of your repentance until the end; for after this day of life, which is given us to prepare for eternity, behold, if we do not improve our time while in this life, then cometh the night of darkness wherein there can be no labor performed.*
>
> *— Alma 34:32–33*

Ifan was on the back bench, in a new coat. He did not say anything. But when the call came at the end of the month for more teams and more teamsters, because the first wagons had found the handcart people at last and it was worse than anybody had said, he was in the bishop's yard with his four oxen yoked before the bishop had finished reading the paper.

VI. The Stripe

November 30, 1856

The news came back over the mountains in pieces all November, and every piece was worse. The first of the handcart companies had been found on the Sweetwater out of flour, and on the night after they climbed the ridge in a snowstorm thirteen of them had died. The second was farther back, at the Platte, and they had sat in the snow waiting for help for nine days, and every morning there were more of them who did not get up. People in the valley said the names of the places as though they were the names of people. Rocky Ridge. Devil's Gate. Red Bluffs.

The last of them came in on the last Sunday in November, in a hundred wagons, while the people were at meeting. The President dismissed the afternoon meeting and told the sisters to go home and get those people something to eat, and wash them and nurse them, and receive them as their own children. The street filled with people and wagons and the steam off the teams.

Gwen went down. She had a wool coat now and a new shawl from Bostwick's store, blue, which she did not like as well. She went along the wagons looking for her husband's oxen, and found them, thin as rails with their hip bones up like tent poles, and Ifan walking beside them with his beard white with frost and his face burned black by the wind, and she did not run to him, because of what was in the wagon.

In the back of the wagon, among the others lying in the straw under Bostwick's blankets, there was a girl of about twelve sitting up. Her feet were wrapped in rags and her hands were wrapped in rags and her face had the look all their faces had, of somebody who had been looking a long way off for a long time. Around her shoulders, crossed on her chest and tied behind, she had a grey flannel shawl with a red stripe along the border.

Ifan said she had been put into his wagon on the far side of the pass, wrapped in it up to the eyes, and had not taken it off since. Her mother and father were in the ground somewhere back along the Platte. She was from Stockport. She had not said ten words the whole way.

Gwen climbed up into the wagon. She said something to the girl in Welsh, which the girl could not have understood, and the girl looked at her for the first time. Then Gwen took the shawl off the girl's shoulders, very gently, and shook the snow out of it over the side of the wagon, and put it back around her, and crossed it on her chest, and tied it behind, tight, the way women tie them at home, so that it would stay.

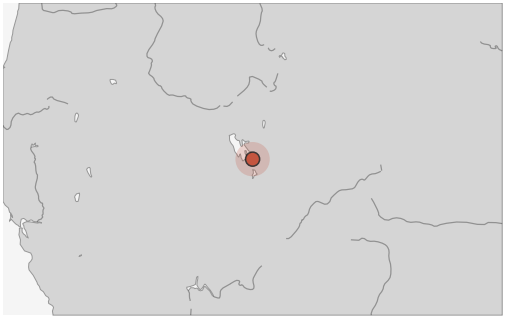
They took her home to the adobe house, which had a fire in it now, and sat her at the plank table under the buffalo robe, and gave her bread.

Background

The verse

> *If a man would hasten towards the good, he should keep his thought away from evil; if a man does what is good slothfully, his mind delights in evil.*
>
> Dhammapada 116, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a poor brahmin and his wife own a single upper garment between them, so only one can go out at a time. She goes to hear the Buddha teach by day, and he goes at night. Moved by the teaching, he wants to give the garment to the Buddha, but selfish thoughts hold him back through the first and second watches of the night. In the last watch he lays it at the Buddha's feet and shouts three times, "I have conquered!" King Pasenadi, who is in the audience, rewards him with pairs of garments, doubling each time as the brahmin gives them all away, until the king makes him keep two pairs. He gives the brahmin two costly blankets, and the brahmin hangs one as a canopy over the Buddha's bed and the other in his own house over the place where a monk takes his meals. Seeing this, the king gives him "the gift of fours." When the monks marvel at how quickly the good deed was rewarded, the Buddha says that had he given in the first watch he would have received sixteens, and in the middle watch eights. Read the full commentary story, or about King Pasenadi.



Great Salt Lake City, Utah Territory

Great Salt Lake City, 1856

After grasshoppers and drought destroyed the crops of 1855, Utah went into a hungry winter. That September, Brigham Young called for a Reformation, and each ward got home missionaries who visited every family and asked searching questions about their religious lives. On October 4, Franklin D. Richards reached the city with word that two late handcart companies, the Willie and Martin companies, were still on the trail. At general conference the next morning, Young called for wagons,

teams, provisions and drivers. Lucy Meserve Smith remembered that "the sisters stripped off their Peticoats stockings and every thing they could spare, right there in the Tabernacle," as recorded by the Church Historian's Press. The first rescue party left on October 7 with sixteen wagonloads of supplies.

The Willie company was found on the Sweetwater River, out of flour. After the climb over Rocky Ridge, thirteen people died in a single night. The Martin company, caught by a blizzard near the last crossing of the North Platte, lost fifty-six people while it waited for help at Red Bluffs. The Willie company reached Salt Lake on November 9 and the Martin company on November 30, and Young told the Saints to take the survivors into their homes. The Welsh in the valley had come mostly through the work of Dan Jones, who led more than 300 Welsh converts out of Liverpool in 1849 and oversaw the first Welsh Book of Mormon.

After the story of the brahmin Culla Ekasāṭaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 116). The original. Scripture from the Book of Mormon. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

9.2

The Recall Card

Behold, thou art made whole: sin no more, lest a worse thing befall thee.
— John 5:14

So here's what I heard, up in Coon Rapids.

I. The Booth

Coon Rapids, Minnesota · April to September 1991

Every hockey family owed the Boosters twenty hours a season. You could work concessions at the arena, or you could sell pull-tabs. Curt Lundeen had a boy in Squirts, and he took the booth at the Tamarack Lounge on Tuesday and Thursday nights.

The booth was a plexiglass box at the end of the bar, with a stool, a cash drawer and three clear bins of tickets. A ticket cost a dollar. It was two layers of cardboard, and on the back were five perforated tabs with a row of pictures under each. Three of the right picture in a row paid something. Most rows paid nothing. A game came in a case of twenty-four hundred tickets, and the flare that came with it was taped to the glass and told you every winner in the case, two at two hundred and fifty dollars and on down. When a big one was cashed, the seller crossed it off. Anybody standing at the bar could look at a bin and at the flare and form an opinion. The man on the stool did not have to form one. He had sold the tickets and he knew the count.

That was why there was an index card inside the glass, typed, at eye level. SELLERS DO NOT PLAY. It was signed M.E.

M.E. was Marlys Engstrom. She had managed the Boosters' gambling for ten years, since the first case of tickets. Her own boys had been out of

hockey for five of those, and nobody had found a way to ask her why she still did it. She closed out every game herself, at her kitchen table, to the dollar. She sang alto at Zion Lutheran and counted the offering there the same way. By day she was the hygienist at Dr. Paulson's office on Hanson Boulevard, where she had cleaned the teeth of half the association. She was a Lindquist from Swift County. An uncle of hers had been an auctioneer out there, and she had his way of saying about a third of what she knew.

She cleaned Curt's teeth the last day of April. At the desk on his way out the girl handed him a postcard and a pen, and he wrote his own name and address on it, as he had every six months for years.

In May the outside sales job at the box plant went to Kevin Brandt, who was twenty-seven. Curt was thirty-six. He had been on the inside desk in Fridley for eleven years, quoting corrugated over the phone. He took it well at work. He took it to the Tamarack that Thursday, which was slow, and told Rollie Voss, who tended bar.

Rollie listened to all of it. He wiped down the rail.

You know what would take your mind off that, he said. *What's left in the Double Play?*

Four hundred. A little under.

Both two-fifties still up?

Curt looked at the flare, though he did not have to. *Both.*

Well?

I can't play my own box, Rollie.

I can. Give me forty out of your pocket.

Rollie bought forty tickets through the slot, like any customer, and walked them around to the booth door. Curt opened them in his lap, under the counter. The nineteenth one was three gold bars in a row. Rollie cashed it for him and kept a twenty, and Curt drove home with two hundred and thirty dollars he had not left the house with. He had not thought about Kevin Brandt for an hour and a half.

That was the worst thing that could have happened to him.

He did it again the week Brandt got a company Taurus. He did it the night the furnace man said two more winters at the outside, and the

night Karen's sister announced Disney World. He was particular for a while. He never did it on a good day, and he noticed that about himself with some approval. He opened them below the counter and dropped the dead ones in a Kemps ice cream pail under the stool, and at closing he carried the pail out to the dumpster himself. By Labor Day he was carrying it out twice a night.

The first of it had been pocket money. After that it came from an envelope behind the paint cans on his workbench. In March there had been six hundred and forty dollars in the envelope, toward a snowblower.

II. The Puck

The Tamarack Lounge · Saturday, October 26

SATURDAY WAS NOT HIS NIGHT. DONNA, WHO SOLD WEEKENDS, had a wedding, and Marlys needed the booth covered. He said he would take it. On Friday the regional manager had read Brandt's third-quarter numbers out loud in the sales meeting.

It meant missing Ryan's first scrimmage, at five o'clock at the arena. He told Karen the Boosters were short. That was true.

The Tamarack was full, with the ballgame on over the bar and the room loud for it. He put a new case in the bin about seven. By nine he had put a hundred and twenty dollars of the envelope through Rollie. The pail was full, and he had started a second pile on the floor.

A little after nine Karen came in with both kids, which she had never done. Ryan was still in his breezers and his jersey, and his hair was stuck down from the helmet. He came straight through the crowd to the booth and held a puck flat against the plexiglass, level with his father's face. There was a strip of white tape across it with the date in ballpoint.

First one, Ryan said. The glass took most of his voice. *It went in off my skate. Coach says it counts.*

Curt had six tickets open in his lap. He said that was great. He put his hand up flat on his own side of the glass, where the puck was. What he was thinking, with his boy's face eight inches away, was that there were

about three hundred left in the bin and one two-fifty, and that Karen was standing where she could see Rollie.

They stayed ten minutes. He was glad about the goal. It was like being glad through glass.

The postcard had come the Monday before, in his own handwriting. *Wednesday, Oct. 30, 4:30. Marlys.*

She had not needed anyone to tell her. Since June the Tuesday and Thursday games had been closing oddly. The big winners came out late in the case, in a bunch, and the bartender cashed them. Then Donna had mentioned the pail. Marlys did not telephone. She knew when he was due.

III. Six Months

Dr. Paulson's office · Wednesday, October 30

TUESDAY HAD BEEN SIXTY-FIVE DEGREES. WEDNESDAY NEVER got above freezing, and the sky over Hanson Boulevard was the color of a nickel.

She put the bib on him and tipped him back. Before she picked up anything else she gave him the hand mirror, and held her own little mirror behind his lower front teeth so that he could see the backs of them.

See that?

There was a ridge along the gumline, yellow-white, like the scale in a teakettle.

That's six months, she said. *You don't feel it going on. It goes on a little every day and it gets hard. Then the next goes on over it.*

She took the mirror away and went to work. For some minutes there was the scrape of the scaler and the suction, and the radio at the front desk, which was on the weather. Then she took both hands out of his mouth and sat back on her stool.

Curt. Is it true you've been playing your own box?

He looked at the light. There was nothing else up there to look at.

Yes.

Since when?

May.

She did not say anything for a moment. Above the mask her eyes were the same as when she was counting.

Well, that was dumb, she said. *You're the one person in that bar who's supposed to be on the other side of the glass.*

I know it.

How much?

Five fifty-five. He had not known he had the figure until he said it.

It doesn't stay five fifty-five. It only goes the one direction. She picked the scaler up again and held it. *I can take off what's on there today. I can't do a thing about tomorrow. That's you.*

Then she told him how it would be, in the voice she used for flossing.

You're in the booth Tuesday. I'm not taking you out of it. You don't buy. Not out of your box, not through Rollie, not at the Legion on the way home, and not a scratch ticket at the SuperAmerica. And you tell Karen before I see her in church.

What about Rollie?

I'll talk to Rollie's boss about Rollie. Open.

She finished the lowers and polished. He rinsed and spat. At the desk the girl gave him the postcard, and he addressed it to himself again. Marlys took it from him and wrote in the date, *April 29, 4:30.* Under the date she wrote something else, small, and turned the card face down in the box with the others.

You'll get that in the spring, she said.

But he had seen it. He looked it up that night at the kitchen table, after the kids were down. The only Bible he could find in the house was one Karen's grandmother had left, an American Standard with a zipper.

> *Afterward Jesus findeth him in the temple, and said unto him, Behold, thou art made whole: sin no more, lest a worse thing befall thee.*
>
> *— John 5:14*

He ran his tongue along the backs of his lower teeth. They were as smooth as the inside of a cup.

He did not tell Karen that night.

IV. Twenty-Eight Inches

Coon Rapids · Halloween and after

It started snowing Thursday before noon. By the time the kids went out there were eight inches down and more coming sideways. Ryan was a Ninja Turtle over a snowsuit. Kristin was a princess, and nothing of the princess showed but the crown, taped to her hood. They did both sides of the street and came in with their pillowcases full of snow.

He told Karen after they were asleep. He went down and got the envelope and put it on the table in front of her. There were eighty-five dollars in it.

She counted it. Then she looked for some time at the kitchen window, where it was coming down through the yard light as if somebody were emptying a sack.

Then I guess you're shoveling, she said.

He shoveled Friday morning, and it was over his boots. He shoveled Friday at dark. He shoveled twice on Saturday, and when he came out Sunday the plow had been by again and laid a wall of gray chunks across the end of the driveway, hip high. The airport said twenty-eight inches when it quit. Don Carlson across the street ran his Toro out to the curb in twenty minutes each time and stood watching Curt over the top of his own bank.

Want me to come across with this?

No, Curt said. *Thanks, Don.*

He threw it one scoop at a time up on a pile by the mailbox, and by Sunday night the pile was taller than Ryan.

The roads were open Tuesday. The Tamarack had about thirty people in it. He sat down in the booth and squared the cash drawer. Around nine Rollie came down the rail with a twenty folded the long way between two fingers. He raised his eyebrows.

Curt shook his head.

Rollie shrugged and put the twenty in his shirt pocket. A man in a Polaris jacket came up to the slot and bought five. Curt counted them out of the bin and pushed them through. Then he reached under the stool for the ice cream pail, turned it upside down on the floor, and put his feet on it.

Background

The verse

> *If a man commits a sin, let him not do it again; let him not delight in sin: pain is the outcome of evil.*
>
> Dhammapada 117, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary's story is a few lines long. The monk Seyyasaka grows discontented with the celibate life and says so to the monk he lives with, Lāḷudāyi, who puts him up to breaking a rule of the order. It is the first of the thirteen saṅghādisesa rules, the one against masturbation, and the monastic code tells Seyyasaka's case as the reason the rule was made. After that, every time he feels discontent he does it again. The Buddha hears, sends for him, and asks whether the report is true. Seyyasaka says that it is. The Buddha calls him a foolish man for acting so against his state, lays the observance of the rules on him, tells him that such a course leads only to suffering, and speaks the verse, whose last line says that the heaping up of wrong is painful. Read the full commentary story. This retelling keeps the shape of the story and changes the habit. Curt's is another private one, taken up for relief on a friend's advice, forbidden to him by his place, and repeated until it is a pile.

Coon Rapids, Minnesota

Pull-tabs, youth hockey and the snow, 1991

Minnesota legalized bingo for nonprofit groups in 1945 and pull-tabs in 1981. By 1989 charitable gambling in the state took in more than a billion dollars a year, the most in the country, and most of it was paper pull-tabs sold from booths in bars for the benefit of veterans' posts, Lions clubs, fire relief associations and youth hockey. Each organization has a licensed gambling manager who answers for the games. The law as revised in 1990 capped a ticket at two dollars and a prize at two hundred and fifty, and required a flare to be posted for every game and the big winners to be posted as they were paid. State law now bars sellers from playing at the site where they work; the card inside the glass in this story is the Boosters' own. The Tamarack Lounge and everyone in it are invented. Coon Rapids is a real suburb north of Minneapolis.

Youth hockey associations in Minnesota lean on these games to pay for ice time, and commonly ask each family for a set number of volunteer hours a season. Squirts are the nine- and ten-year-olds, and breezers are what Minnesotans call hockey pants. The last Tuesday of October 1991 was sixty-five degrees in the Twin Cities. Snow began on Thursday, October 31, and did not stop until Sunday. The Halloween Blizzard left 28.4 inches at the Minneapolis–St. Paul airport, still the largest single snowstorm in the cities' records, with 8.2 inches of it on Halloween itself. Children went out in costumes over snowsuits. The hard deposit a hygienist scrapes away is calculus, which builds up in layers when plaque is left on the teeth.

After the story of the Elder Seyyasaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 117). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.3

The Fanner

I have a heaven to maintain.
— "Not Weary Yet," Slave Songs of the United States (1867)

This is the way the praise house had it, on St. Helena Island.

I. The Pond

Long Pond plantation, St. Helena Island · September 1862

The white people left Long Pond on the day of the Gun Shoot. That was the seventh of November, when the Yankee ships beat down the forts at Bay Point and Hilton Head, and the sound came across the water all morning like somebody dragging furniture over a floor upstairs. The master's family went off toward the main in the flats with what they could carry. They called on the people to come with them, and the people went into the woods and stayed there until the boats were gone.

That winter the cotton agents came, and in the spring the superintendents, young men from Massachusetts with pay books. Now the people worked the cotton for the Government at so much a task, and the pay came late, or came as paper to spend at the agent's store. In May soldiers walked down the road and took the able men off to Hilton Head without a day's warning. In July the transports brought the Edisto people, whose island the Government had given up, and set them ashore on St. Helena with their fowls and pigs, and Long Pond took in its share. After that came the fever months.

Brother March was leader of the praise house at Long Pond. He was a lean man past sixty who had been the plantation carpenter, which meant he had made its coffins, and he had made nine since the first of August.

He wore the same osnaburg he had worn on the day of the Gun Shoot. When the people went up to the big house that November and came away with looking-glasses and feather beds, he stayed on the street. He ate from a white bowl with a blue rim, chipped in three places, that the big-house cook had thrown out years before, and he would not sit at any table where there was plenty. If he took his dinner from anyone it was from a widow with five children, or from the lame. He said the ones with the least had the hardest time finding anybody to give to.

When the ninth coffin was in the ground he went into the wilderness. Everyone on the islands knew what that was. A young person who began to seek was sent out to a place in the woods to pray alone until something was shown them, and Brother March had sent out forty or more in his time. Now he went himself, an old man, carrying only the bowl, and he was gone seven days.

On the seventh morning he got up from the foot of his tree. His head was light and his knees were bad. He stood and went over in his mind the doors where he might ask. There was the big-house kitchen, where Mr. Kimball the superintendent had Government bacon and would have sat him down gladly. There was the driver's wife, who had flour. He passed them by. Then he saw the Edisto girl who minded the birds, as plainly as if he stood at the pond himself.

Is there faith in her? he asked, and knew there was. *Can she do this for me?* He knew that too. *She will do it, and more will come back to her for it than she has any way to guess.*

He picked up the bowl and walked out of the woods.

• • •

The long pond was the low ground behind the quarters that had given the place its name. It would not grow cotton. The people had always planted it in rice for themselves, in the evenings after task, and this year the rice was theirs and nobody's to weigh. By September it stood in the milk, and the ricebirds came down on it out of the north in clouds. So the street had put the girl there to keep them off.

Her name was Affy and she was about sixteen. She had come off Edisto in July on the deck of a transport, alone. Her mother was in the ground on Edisto. Her father had been carried up to the main by his master in the week of the Gun Shoot, and nobody could tell her where. She slept in the corn house and owned one frock. For minding the pond she was to have rice when the rice came in. Until then she had what people brought her, which some days was a potato and some days was nothing.

She had two shingles to clap and her voice, and she walked the bank from first light. Along the south side the earliest heads had begun to turn, and she was allowed a double handful. When the old man came out of the trees she was crouched over a lightwood fire with half a broken skillet, parching them. Green rice will not pound. Shake it in hot iron, though, and the hull dries and splits, and you can rub it off between your palms and blow the trash away, and what is left is hot and sweet and tastes of smoke. It was all she would have that day.

He did not come to her. He stopped a good way off, where the path met the pond bank, and stood with the bowl in both hands, looking at the ground.

She knew who he was. She had seen him on the bench in the praise house, and she had not supposed he knew there was such a person as herself. When she saw him standing there her whole heart went out to him, and gladness came up through her from the soles of her feet, so that her hands shook.

Wait, sir, she said. *Wait one minute.*

She rubbed off the hulls fast, and blew, and came along the bank with the skillet and tipped all of it into his bowl, every grain. Then she got down on her knees in the path.

Whatever you found out there, she said, *let me have a share in it.*

Let it be so, daughter, said Brother March. He said a short blessing over her head and turned back toward the street, eating slowly as he went, the way a man eats after seven days.

Affy stayed on her knees until he was out of sight. Then she got up and started back along the bank to her fire. She was not thinking about the birds. She was thinking about the rice going out of the skillet into the

bowl, the sound it made, and that he had taken it. She had not been so happy since Edisto.

There was a hole in the bank where the old drain log went through, and a rattlesnake lay in the mouth of it. The old man had passed it twice. He wore a pair of soldier's brogans somebody had given him and a coat that came below his knees, and the snake had found nothing there to strike. The girl was barefoot. It took her above the ankle, and she went down in the path where she stood.

They say she died still thinking about the bowl.

II. The House

The same day

SHE WOKE THE WAY YOU WAKE AFTER SLEEPING IN THE DAYtime, not sure where the door is.

She was in a house. This is how it was told on St. Helena, and nobody who told it ever made it smaller. The house was gold all through, and it was thirty miles from the front door to the back, and no hammer or nail had gone into it. She herself had grown in it as tall as a pine. She had on a new frock that had never been on anyone else, and another over that. A thousand women stood in the hall, and every one of them knew her name.

Over the door, where a person coming up the steps could not miss it, hung a fanner. It was the same wide shallow basket they fanned rice in on every street in the islands, sewn round and round from the middle. This one was gold, and it was full of rice, hulled and clean, and the rice was gold too. It hung there so that whoever came would know how she had got her house.

She stood in the doorway and looked at all of it. *What did I ever do to come by this?* she asked herself, and knew at once. It was the skillet of rice.

Then she thought: *If that little brought all this, I cannot sit down now. I have this to keep. I will go and do for him, the big things and the small, and make it sure.*

Before day she took a gold broom, and a gold pan to carry off the sweepings, and went down to Long Pond.

III. The Latch-Hole

Three mornings

Brother March's house was the last on the street. He had lived in its two rooms alone since his wife died. On the first morning, when he came in from his prayers, the floor was swept. It was swept into the corners, and the sand before the door was swept too, in the long curved marks a broom leaves. His water gourd was full and stood on the shelf where he could reach it.

He stood and looked. *One of the boys,* he thought. Three young ones were seeking under him that fall, and one of them, a boy called Scipio, was forever underfoot wanting to be of use.

The second morning it was the same, floor and yard and water. He thought the same thing, and meant to speak to the boy about pride.

The third morning he had not yet gone out. He was on his knees by the bed in the dark, and he heard the broom. It was going over the floor of the front room in slow strokes. He got up and put his eye to the hole in the door where the latchstring ran through.

The room was full of light that was neither fire nor day. In the middle of it a shape taller than the room should have held was bending and sweeping.

Who is that sweeping?

It is me, sir. Affy. Your child Affy.

I have no child by that name.

He did not. The street had buried the Edisto girl by torchlight on the night he came out of the woods, and had laid the broken skillet on the grave with her gourd, as the last things she used. He had slept through it. Nobody thought to tell him she was the one who had fed him, because nobody knew she had.

Sir, I was the girl minding birds at the pond. I gave you the parched rice. Going back along the bank a snake struck me, and I died glad, and woke in a

house in heaven. It came to me through you. So I said, I will do for him, the big things and the small, and make it sure. That is why I came.

It was you swept here yesterday? And the day before? You filled the gourd?

Yes, sir.

He was quiet a while on his side of the door.

Go on from here, daughter. What you have done is done, and never mind about it. But do not come to this house again.

Sir, do not ruin me. Let me do for you. Let me make it sure.

Go on. Some day the exhorters will be sitting up on the bench with their palmetto fans, and I will not give them this to say: I heard tell a spirit came to Brother March and swept his house and drew his water. Do not come here any more. Turn your feet some other way.

A leader who had that said of him was no better than a root man with a haunt to fetch for him. His praise house was finished, and every seeker he had ever sent out was in doubt.

Do not ruin me, sir, she said, and said it again, and a third time.

She is not hearing me, the old man thought. He opened the door. *You do not know your own measure,* he said, and he snapped his fingers at her, as you would at a hen that had got into the house.

She could not stay after that. She went up through the roof as smoke does and stood in the air over the street in the gray before day, as high as the tops of the live oaks, with her hands pressed together.

Do not take from me what I have got, she called down. *Let me make it sure.*

Then she wept. She stood in the air over the quarters at Long Pond and cried aloud like a child shut out of a house.

IV. The Fanner

The first house on the street

The first house on the street was Maum Binah's. It was the praise house, since the praise house was always the house of the oldest person on the place, and nobody at Long Pond could say how old Maum Binah was. She had fanned the street's rice since before the driver was born. When the rice was cut and pounded they brought it to her door

IN THE MORTAR, AND SHE SAT ON HER STOOL WITH THE WIDE fanner on her knees and threw the rice up to the wind and caught it, and threw it up again, until there was no trash left in it. Half the street had come into the world through her two hands. Forty years back, when a carpenter's boy called March first went out into the wilderness to seek, she was the one he came to in the mornings to tell what he had seen, and she was the one who told him when it was enough.

Everybody on the street heard something that morning and took it for wind, or a marsh hen. Maum Binah knew what it was.

She did not get up from her stool. People saw her on it at sunrise through her open door, with the fanner in her lap. Others, just as truthful, looked up and saw her sitting in the air above the last house on the street, face to face with the tall girl, as near as two women shelling peas on a step. Light came off her the way it comes off the creek at noon.

Daughter, she said. *Hush now.*

The girl hushed.

It was for my son March to hold himself back. That is his work, and he did right by it. But one who has found out what it is to do good says, This one thing is all I have to do, and cannot see around it. She is not wrong either. Nothing else makes anybody glad for long, here or yonder.

Then she raised a song in her old cracked voice, as she raised it in the praise house on Sunday nights. The girl knew it, and could not help coming in under her.

> *O me no weary yet, O me no weary yet. I have a witness in my heart, O me no weary yet.*
>
> *I have a heaven to maintain.*
>
> *— "Not Weary Yet," Slave Songs of the United States (1867)*

It was never him, Maum Binah said. *He had the bowl in his hands that day, that is all. Somebody is holding out a bowl every day God sends. You did it once, and you see what it was. Do it again. Then do it again. Set your whole mind there and let it be sweet to you. It heaps up.*

She tipped the fanner on her knees a little, to show her.

They say that when the girl heard this she stood up taller in the air than she had been, taller than the pines, taller than anything on St. Helena, and that she had stopped crying. She had come into something on her own account, and nobody could send her out of it.

• • •

After that September it began to be told from one plantation to the next. A woman on the Seaside road, down with fever and her man gone for a soldier, woke before day to find her floor swept into the corners, the sand at her door swept in long curves, and her gourd full. So did an old man at the far end of the island who was too stiff to draw his own water. So did a girl lying in with her first baby. It was never the same house two mornings running, and so nobody could have it to say that a spirit kept house for them. People did not talk about it much. But the children had a thing they sang when they found a yard swept that nobody had swept. The men took it with them into the regiment that winter, and one of the Yankee officers wrote it down.

Massa Jesus give me a little broom
For to sweep my heart clean,
And I will try, by de grace of God,
To win my way home.

— "Fare Ye Well," as sung in the First South Carolina Volunteers (T. W. Higginson, Army Life in a Black Regiment, 1870)

Brother March led the praise house at Long Pond eleven years more, and he never spoke of the three mornings. But every September, when the first heads turned along the south side of the pond, he cut a double handful and parched it himself over a lightwood fire. He carried it up the street in the blue-rimmed bowl to the first house. Maum Binah, and after her whoever was oldest, poured it into the fanner and threw it up to the wind. What was light blew off across the yard. What was rice came down. Then she threw it up again.

Background

The verse

> *If a man does what is good, let him do it again; let him delight in it: happiness is the outcome of good.*
>
> Dhammapada 118, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Kassapa comes out of seven days of meditation and looks for someone poor to receive his first meal from. He chooses a young woman who is guarding a rice field and parching rice she has gathered. She pours it into his bowl with joy and asks for a share in the truth he has seen. On her way back a snake bites her, and she dies and is reborn as a goddess in a golden mansion, with a golden vessel of golden rice hung at its door to show how she came there. Wanting to make her good fortune sure, she goes each dawn to sweep the elder's cell and set out his water. On the third morning he sees her radiance through the keyhole and sends her away, so that no preacher may one day say a goddess waited on Kassapa. She stands weeping in the air. The Buddha hears, appears before her, says that Kassapa was right to restrain himself and that she is right to want to do good, and speaks the verse. Her name afterward is Lājā, Parched Rice. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa, the most austere of the Buddha's great disciples, who made a practice of taking alms from the poor.

St. Helena Island, South Carolina

St. Helena Island, 1862

On November 7, 1861, a Union fleet took the two forts guarding Port Royal Sound. The planters of the South Carolina Sea Islands fled inland, and about ten thousand enslaved people stayed where they were. The islanders called that day the Gun Shoot. What followed is known as the Port Royal Experiment: Treasury cotton agents, then Northern superintendents and teachers, with the people working the abandoned plantations for wages that often came late or in store credit. In May 1862

General Hunter's soldiers took the able-bodied men off the plantations for a regiment without warning, and in July the Army gave up Edisto Island and carried its people to St. Helena. By that winter Sea Island men were enlisting in the First South Carolina Volunteers. The National Park Service tells the larger story. Long Pond and everyone on it are invented.

Each plantation had its praise house. The Philadelphia teacher Laura Towne, who came to St. Helena in April 1862, wrote that it was "always the cabin of the oldest person in the little village," and in 1864 she visited an old African-born woman known as a great "spiritual mother" with "tremendous influence over her spiritual children" (Letters and Diary of Laura M. Towne). Young people who were "seeking" went out alone to pray in the woods under the guidance of such an elder. Towne also noted the small ponds of the island planted in rice, which was pounded in a mortar and winnowed in a wide coiled basket called a fanner; in the old rice country people were set to keep the ricebirds off the ripening grain. Objects last used by the dead were laid on their graves. The two songs come from this place and these years. "Not Weary Yet" was taken down in the Port Royal islands by Charles P. Ware, a superintendent on St. Helena, and printed in Slave Songs of the United States (1867); "Fare Ye Well" was sung by the Sea Island soldiers of Thomas Wentworth Higginson's regiment and printed in his Army Life in a Black Regiment (1870). Both are quoted as those books give them, and the spelling is the collectors'.

After the story of the goddess Lājā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 118). The original. Songs from Slave Songs of the United States (1867) and T. W. Higginson, Army Life in a Black Regiment (1870). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.4

Going-Home Money

He treads on the hoar-frost; the strong ice will come (by and by).
— Yi King, Appendix IV, tr. James Legge

Ngóh tēng gwo gám góng, on Mamo Street.

I. The Can

Hilo, Territory of Hawaii · 1945

Chun Kwai kept a store on Mamo Street, a block up from the bay, and for twenty years nobody who came to his counter hungry had gone out of it with empty hands.

He sold rice in hundred-pound bags and salt salmon out of a barrel, shoyu by the gallon tin, kerosene, Bull Durham, dried shrimp, cotton palaka shirts for the cane fields, and crack seed in tall glass jars that the children of the Hilo side pressed their faces against on the way home from school. Behind the counter, on a nail, hung the book. Everybody knew the book. A family from Wainaku or Pāpaʻikou came in at the end of a short month and said *put it on the book, Mr. Chun,* and he wet his pencil and put it on the book, and some of it came back and a good deal of it never did, and he did not seem to mind. When the Army took the Japanese priests and schoolmasters and the officers of the Japanese societies away in December 1941, and their wives stood at his counter not knowing what to say, he put them on the book without a word and never once asked. People said Chun Kwai had paid for the new roof on the Chinese school out of his own pocket, and for a good many funerals, and for a boy's passage to the medical college in Honolulu, though he would not say so if you asked him.

He was fifty-one that year, short and broad, bald under a grey felt hat he wore indoors and out. He had come to Hilo in 1912 from a village in Heungshan, outside Canton, with his mother and a cardboard suitcase and a debt to a cousin, and he had worked off the debt cutting cane at Wainaku before he was twenty. Three-quarters of the Chinese in the islands had come from Heungshan. On the Hilo side you could still hear the village speech of it on Mamo Street on a Saturday, though the children answered in English.

Under the back step, where the kitchen door let out toward the river, he kept a Hills Bros. coffee can.

Nobody knew it was there but his mother. Every month since 1919 he had rolled some bills in oilcloth and put them in the can and put the can back in the ground and set the step on top of it. It was his going-home money. When there was enough he would take his mother back across the ocean to the village and build a house there with a second story and a well in the yard, and she would die in the place she was born, as she had always said she would. When the war ended in August he sat up one night in the kitchen and counted it, and it was enough. Next year, he told her. When the boats run right again. Next year.

His mother was seventy-six. Everybody, including her son, called her Ah Mah. Over the doorway between the store and the kitchen she had pasted a print she brought from Heungshan rolled in her sleeve: a lady in a red jacket, round-faced and calm, with a baby on one arm and two little boys holding her skirt, and a peony behind her the size of a cabbage. At New Year other families put up new door prints. Ah Mah never changed this one. She said this one was good. She said the lady watched the door.

Kwai's daughter Lin was eight, a late child, and her mother had died having her. Lin talked to the lady in the doorway when nobody was listening, and told her things, and sometimes, she said later, the lady listened back.

II. April Fool

Mamo Street · April 1, 1946

It was a Monday. Lin was in the store early, before school, eating a manapua out of a paper and watching Ah Fong sweep. Ah Fong was her father's cousin's son, thin and serious, who kept the book and the accounts in a clear small hand and wanted to be a bookkeeper at the bank.

A boy ran past the open door shouting *tidal wave, tidal wave,* and Ah Fong leaned on his broom and said *yeah, April fool,* and went on sweeping.

Then more people were running, and they were not running away from the water. They were running toward it. Lin went out to the corner in her school shoes and looked down Mamo Street to the bay, and the bay was gone.

She said for the rest of her life that she could not make anybody understand what that was like. The water had pulled back past the breakwater as if somebody had pulled a cloth off a table. The bottom of Hilo Bay lay out in the morning sun, black rock and grey sand and weed, and fish were flopping on it, hundreds of them, silver, and boys were running out across the wet sand with buckets to pick them up. A sampan lay on its side. The air smelled like the inside of a shell.

Ah Mah came out of the kitchen with her hair still down and took Lin by the wrist hard enough to leave a mark and pulled her up Mamo Street, uphill, away from the bay, without one word. Lin looked back over her shoulder and saw the water come.

It did not come like a wave at the beach. It came like the whole ocean walking up onto the land, brown, high as the second story of the Hilo Iron Works, carrying things. It carried a roof with a man on it. It carried a railroad car. It went over the railroad bridge on the Wailuku River so that the bridge was simply not there. It came up over Front Street into the stores on the ocean side. It went across the low ground of Shinmachi, the Japanese town by the Wailoa, where there were houses and a macaroni

factory and a lumber mill and a kamaboko shop, and when it went back out it took most of Shinmachi with it.

There was more than one wave. Nobody had told them that. The people who had gone back down after the first one to look were caught by the next, and the next was bigger.

When it was over Kwai was standing in the mud behind his store with his hat gone. The front of the store had held. The back room was torn open and the kitchen half gone, the stove on its side in the yard, and where the back step had been there was a hole full of brown water with a dead fish in it. He got down on his knees and put his arms into the hole to the shoulder and felt along the bottom with his hands. Ah Fong got down beside him. They dug for an hour. The can was gone, and the oilcloth, and twenty-six years of going home.

Ah Mah stood in what was left of the kitchen doorway looking up at her print. The lady was still there on the doorframe. The water had come up the frame to the height of a child's chin and gone down again, and it had left a brown line straight across the lady's red skirt and across the faces of the two little boys.

Ninety-six people died in Hilo that morning. Up the coast at Laupāhoehoe the wave took the schoolchildren and their teachers off the point where they had been playing on the sand before the bell. Kwai's best customer for twenty years, Kubo the fish-cake maker, had lived in Shinmachi with his wife and two daughters above their shop. They found Mrs. Kubo on Wednesday. They did not find the others.

That week every bag of rice in Kwai's storeroom was wet with salt water, and rice that has been in the sea is good for one thing. He built a fire in the street in front of the store and set the big pot on it and made jook, and gave it out in tin cups and jelly glasses and anything people brought, to anyone who came up from the bay. He cooked for six days. On the seventh the rice was gone.

III. The Cottage

Waiānuenue Avenue · May to October 1946

HARUO KUBO CAME HOME IN MAY.

He had volunteered for the 442nd in 1943, at twenty-two, with half the Nisei boys on the Hilo side, and in October 1944, in the forests of the Vosges in France, a German shell had burst in the trees over his head. He came to in a field hospital and never saw anything again. The Army sent him to a hospital in Pennsylvania and then to a school for blinded soldiers at Avon, in Connecticut, in an old boys' school with stone buildings, where he learned to shave by touch and cross a street with a cane and read with his fingers. When they were done with him they put him on a ship. A Red Cross woman met him at the pier in Hilo, and on the drive into town, very carefully, she told him.

He asked her to take him to the lot. She led him by the elbow across the ruined ground of Shinmachi, between the foundation stones, and he stood where she told him the house had been and tapped the ground in front of him with his cane, and there was nothing there to tap.

Kwai heard by noon. He closed the store, which he never did, and walked down to the lot, and stood beside the young man a while without saying anything, and then said, *Harry. It's Chun. From Mamo Street.* Haruo put out his hand and Kwai took it.

Kwai owned a cottage up Waiānuenue Avenue, on the high ground above the town where the wave had not reached, two rooms and a lanai and a mango tree, which he had rented to a schoolteacher until the schoolteacher married. He gave it to Haruo. He did not rent it to him. He had a carpenter put a rail along the lanai steps and a second rail from the steps to the road, and paid for it, and did not mention it again.

After that Kwai went up the hill three times a day. Early, before he opened the store, he carried a pot of jook with green onion and slivers of ginger on the top, and a fried egg wrapped in wax paper. In the middle of the morning he went again, with the pills from the drugstore on Keawe Street, because there were still pieces of the shell in Haruo's back that the surgeons had left there, and a bottle of the liniment that smelled of

camphor and wintergreen. In the evening he brought plumeria from the tree behind the store, and a bundle of incense, and on Saturdays a clean shirt.

Haruo had made a butsudan for his family out of a fruit crate, on a shelf by the window, and Lin, who went up with her father in the evenings, read him the names he had written on slips of paper in his blind, careful printing, so he would know the slips were still in their order. He put the plumeria in a jelly glass in front of them. He could tell by the smell when a flower had turned.

The boys found him within a week. Boys always find a man like that. They came up Waiānuenue after school and sat on the lanai steps, Japanese boys and Chinese boys and a Filipino boy whose father had come on the boat that winter and a big Portuguese boy named Medeiros, and they asked him about France and about the war, and mostly he did not answer, and they kept coming anyway. He taught them to tie knots blindfolded. He taught them how to hear where a car was on the road. When Kwai came up the steps in the evening the boys all looked first at his hands, to see what he was carrying.

• • •

On the first of September the sugar workers struck, twenty-six thousand of them, on thirty-three of the thirty-four plantations in the islands. On the Hilo side every mill went quiet at once. You could hear the river at night.

Kwai's book filled up. The strikers' families came in and said *put it on the book* and he put it on the book, and by October the book had to be tied shut with string. The union set up soup kitchens and fishing and hunting committees. Men went up the mountain after pigs and out to the reef after fish. A committee of strikers went around to the stores asking for whatever the stores could give, and Kwai gave rice; when rice got hard to come by in the stores and the union had to bring it in from the mainland, he gave what he had left. His mother watched him do it and said nothing. He had no going-home money now. He had a store with half-empty shelves and a book tied with string.

But he went up the hill three times a day. Only now in the morning it was jook with nothing on top, and in the evening it was jook again, with a little dish of ham choy, the salted mustard greens out of the crock.

One evening in October Haruo, eating on the lanai with the bowl held up under his chin, said: *Mr. Chun. Down at your place. They still eating?*

Some. Kwai looked at the bowl. *Jook. Jook and ham choy. That's what there is.*

Haruo finished the bowl and set it down beside him on the boards, where he could find it again.

When I volunteered, he said, *my father gave me a send-off. You remember. He rented the hall. Two hundred people. A whole ahi on the table, sashimi, sekihan, the good sake from Honolulu, a band. Nobody in Shinmachi ever saw a party like that. My mother cried all night because of the money.* He was quiet for a while. *You know what I remember? Nobody there was hungry. Not one person. Everybody already ate before they came. I was the guest of honor, I sat up front, and I can't tell you the taste of one single thing.*

The boys on the steps had gone still.

This jook, Haruo said, *I can taste.*

Kwai took the empty bowl and went down the hill with it in the dark.

• • •

At home Ah Mah was sitting in the kitchen they had rebuilt out of salvaged boards, shelling peanuts into a pan. Her father had been a village schoolmaster in Heungshan and she could say whole pages of the old books with her eyes closed. She looked at her son's face and set down the pan and said a thing out of the Book of Changes, in the old words, which Lin did not understand then and looked up in English many years later, in a library in Honolulu, and copied out by hand.

> *The family that accumulates goodness is sure to have superabundant happiness, and the family that accumulates evil is sure to have superabundant misery.*
>
> *— Yi King, Appendix IV, sect. ii, ch. II, 5 (tr. James Legge, 1882)*

Then she pointed with her chin out the kitchen window, up past the town and the cane and the forest, to where the top of Mauna Kea stood clear in the last light with the first snow of the season on it.

Does it snow all at once? she said. *First the frost. Then the ice. It takes a long time.*

IV. The Door Lady

The kitchen behind the store · late October

THIS IS THE PART AH MAH TOLD, AND LIN TOLD AFTER HER, and you can believe it or not.

The lady in the doorway had watched the door for thirty-four years, in Heungshan and in Hilo. In all that time she had never once been able to speak to Chun Kwai. When a man is rich and strong in his own house, the door spirits keep quiet; they can only stand there. But she had not liked the blind boy from the start. The first time Haruo came down Mamo Street with his white cane and stood in the store, the corners of the print had curled up off the doorframe as though somebody had set a stove too close to it. She could not abide him, or the boys who followed him, or the people coming through her door with their hands out. There was too much good in them. It made her eyes water like smoke.

Now Kwai was poor. A poor man listens, she thought. So one night late in October, when he sat alone at the kitchen table with a lamp and the book with the string around it, adding columns that would not add, she stepped down off the doorframe and stood in the air in front of him, about a foot above the floor, in her red jacket, with the baby on her arm.

Who is that? said Kwai.

The lady of your door, she said. *I came to give you advice.*

So give it.

You have thrown away everything you had, she said. *Twenty years of rice on the book. The school roof. That cottage. And now you are poor and still you give. The strikers will lose. The plantations always win. Who has ever beaten the sugar companies? When it is over they will go back to work and forget your name, and they will never pay. And three times a day up the hill to a Japanese*

boy, carrying food, when your own village was under the Japanese army for seven years and you have not had one letter from it. Stop. Close the book. Mind the store. In a few years you will have your going-home money again. If you go on like this, in a month you will not have rice for your own mother.

That's what you came to tell me?

Yes.

Kwai put the pencil down. *Then go,* he said. *A hundred thousand like you could stand there and not move me one inch. You live in my house, on my door, and you say this to me? You had no business saying it. Get out of my house.*

And she went, out the kitchen door into the dark, with the baby on her arm and the two little boys holding her skirt.

In the morning Lin came down for breakfast and stopped in the doorway. The print was still pasted to the frame, but it was blank. The red was gone, and the peony, and the faces. There was only old paper, a little yellow, and across the middle of it the brown line of the water.

V. The Ti Leaf

Hilo · November 1946

THE DOOR LADY HAD NOWHERE TO GO. EVERY HOUSE IN HILO already had whatever watched its door, and none of them would make room for her. She walked the town with the children for nights. She went to the earth god in his little house at the edge of the cemetery, and told him what she had said, and asked him to go to Chun Kwai with her and ask that she be let back in. The earth god said, *You said what you had no business saying. I won't go with you.* She crossed the channel to the Four Kings who stand guard in the gates of temples, one with a sword and one with a lute and one with an umbrella and one with a snake, and they said the same. At last, worn out, the children crying, she went all the way up to the Jade Emperor himself.

I have nowhere to live, she told him. *I walk around with these children in my hands. Get me back my door.*

I can't speak to him for you either, said the Jade Emperor. *But I'll tell you what to do. Put on the clothes of the young man who keeps his book. Copy out*

on a leaf every debt that is owed him, and go around and collect it. Then go to the bottom of the bay, where the can went, and bring it up. And there is money in this town with no owner at all; you know where. Put all of it back in that man's store. When you have made up for what you said, then ask his pardon.

• • •

That is the story. What happened in Hilo is this.

The strike ended in the middle of November, after seventy-nine days, and the strikers had won. The companies gave a raise of nearly twenty cents an hour and did away with the old system of perquisites, the company houses and company doctors and company fuel that had always been counted against the pay, and paid it in cash instead. The men went back to the mills. And in the last week of November they began coming into the store on Mamo Street one after another with their hats in their hands to pay what was on the book.

Kwai was astonished. He said so. A man from Pāpaʻikou, laying down bills on the counter, said he was only doing what he was told: the young fellow from the store had come around to the camp on Tuesday with a list and gone house to house, very polite, and said what each family owed to the penny, and said Mr. Chun would be glad of whatever they could bring. Another man said the same. Then a woman from Wainaku.

Ah Fong had been in Honolulu that whole week, at his father's funeral. He had the inter-island ticket stubs in his wallet to prove it.

That night Lin untied the string on the book and opened it, and a ti leaf fell out from between the pages, one long green leaf, and written on it in ink in a small fine hand, not Ah Fong's, not anybody's they knew, was every name in the book and the sum against it.

On the first of December an Okinawan fisherman named Higa, who went out of the river in a sampan, came to the back door of the store with a Hills Bros. coffee can in a gunnysack. It had come up in his net that morning off Coconut Island, he said, eight months under the bay. The can was rusted through like lace. Inside it, rolled in oilcloth, dry as the day it went into the ground, was the going-home money.

And on the morning after that there was an envelope under the front door of the store, with no name on it and no writing at all, and money inside it. Kwai took it to the police station. The police kept it ninety days and nobody came for it, and then they gave it back.

Ah Fong added it all up at the counter, the book and the can and the envelope, and then added it again, and then sat down on a rice bag. It came to everything Kwai had had on the morning of April Fool, to the dollar.

VI. Gion Shōja

Waiānuenue Avenue · the night of December 2

THAT NIGHT KWAI WOKE AND THE KITCHEN WAS FULL OF light. Lin, on the cot in the next room, woke too, and came and stood behind the curtain.

The door lady stood in the air above the kitchen floor, shining so that you could see every board, with the baby on her arm and the two boys at her skirt. Her face was wet.

Who is that? said Kwai, though he knew.

The blind, foolish lady who used to watch your door, she said. *Forgive what I said to you. I was a fool. I did what the Jade Emperor told me. Everything you lost is back in your storeroom. I have paid for my words. I have nowhere to live and I am very tired.*

Kwai sat a long time on the edge of his bed. Then he put on his trousers and his grey hat.

Don't tell me, he said. *Come up the hill and tell him.*

So they went up Waiānuenue Avenue together in the middle of the night, the storekeeper in his hat and the lady walking a foot above the road with her children, and Lin came after them barefoot in her nightgown, keeping to the dark under the trees. The town was asleep. Out on the bay the lights of a ship. The cottage was dark, but Haruo was sitting on the lanai in his undershirt, because he did not sleep much, and never had since France.

He stood up before Kwai said anything. He turned his face to the empty air at Kwai's left shoulder, where the lady was, and bowed to it, a deep, slow bow, the way his mother had taught him to bow at the temple.

Lin said that the lady got down on the boards of the lanai, on her knees, and put her forehead to the floor at Haruo's feet, and stayed there, and the little boys did the same because their mother did.

I didn't know what you were, the lady said into the boards. *I said bad things. Forgive me.*

Haruo was quiet. When he spoke he did not speak English. He said something in Japanese, in the singsong of a thing learned by heart, a thing he had stood up and said in front of the Japanese-school class at the Hongwanji before the war, when the Japanese schools were still open, and Lin did not understand a word of it, except that she heard him say *Gion shōja* twice. Years later, a grown woman, she found it in English in a library in Honolulu, in the same week she found the other thing, and copied it out on the same sheet of paper.

> *The sound of the bell of Gionshoja echoes the impermanence of all things. The hue of the flowers of the teak tree declares that they who flourish must be brought low. Yea, the proud ones are but for a moment, like an evening dream in springtime. The mighty are destroyed at the last, they are but as the dust before the wind.*
>
> *— The Heike Monogatari, Book I, ch. 1 (tr. A. L. Sadler, 1918)*

Then he said it again in his own words, in English, for Kwai and for the lady, standing in his undershirt with one hand on the rail Kwai's carpenter had built.

The sugar companies, he said. *The big men. They did a lot of bad things, a long time, and they were fine. Rich. Nothing happened. Because it wasn't ripe yet. Then it got ripe.* He turned his face toward Kwai. *Other way, too. A man does good, and for a while all he gets is trouble. The wave. The strike. The book with the string on it. Because his good isn't ripe yet. Wait. It gets ripe.*

The lady was still kneeling with her forehead down. Lin said that she began to cry, and then stopped, and that her face, when she lifted it, had

changed; that it was the same face, and different, the way the bay is the same bay when the light comes up on it. Then the shining went out of the air, and there was only the lanai and the mango tree and the three of them in the dark, and the smell of the plumeria in the jelly glass.

• • •

Kwai did not go home.

He had his going-home money back, every dollar, and the boats were running again, and his mother was seventy-seven. But the war in China between the Nationalists and the Communists had started again that summer, and the letters that came from Heungshan said not now. And in the spring Kwai said to his mother at the kitchen table one night, half laughing, that if he went home who was going to make the jook. She did not argue. She died in Hilo in 1951, on Mamo Street, in the room over the store, and was buried in the Chinese cemetery under a stone with the name of her village on it.

Haruo Kubo went to the university in Honolulu on the GI Bill, became a teacher at the school for the blind, and married. Every New Year he came back to Hilo, and before he went anywhere else he stopped at the store on Mamo Street and ate a bowl of jook standing at the counter.

On the morning after the night on the lanai, Lin came down to breakfast and the door lady was back on the frame over the kitchen door, red jacket, peony, round calm face, the baby and the two little boys, the colors as bright as the day Ah Mah brought her over the ocean in her sleeve. Ah Mah never put up a new one. When the store closed in 1972 Lin peeled the print off the frame with a butter knife, an inch at a time, and kept it flat between two pieces of cardboard, and it has gone with the family everywhere since. The colors are still good. Only the water line never came out. It runs straight across all three of them, the lady's red skirt and the faces of the two boys, at the height of a child's chin, where the bay came in.

Background

The verses

> *Even an evil-doer sees happiness as long as his evil deed has not ripened; but when his evil deed has ripened, then does the evil-doer see evil.*
>
> Dhammapada 119, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Even a good man sees evil days, as long as his good deed has not ripened; but when his good deed has ripened, then does the good man see happy days.*
>
> Dhammapada 120, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Anāthapiṇḍika, the great lay donor who bought the Jetavana grove for the Buddha, visits the Teacher three times a day and never goes empty-handed. Merchants default on loans he made them, and a flood sweeps the family treasure buried at the riverbank into the sea, but he goes on giving, though now only rice porridge and sour gruel. The Buddha tells him that no gift given with a pure heart is coarse, and recalls that in a past life, as the brahmin Velāma, he gave an enormous gift where there was no one worthy to receive it. The spirit who lives over the householder's gate, unable to bear the goodness of the monks, finally dares to speak now that he is poor, and urges him to stop giving and mind his business. He throws her out. Homeless with her children, she is turned away by the city's guardian deity and the Four Great Kings, until Sakka, king of the gods, tells her to disguise herself as the steward, collect the debts, recover the treasure from the sea and gather ownerless wealth. She does, and asks pardon, and the householder takes her to the Buddha, who speaks these verses about deeds ripening. Read the full commentary story, or about Anāthapiṇḍika. The Japanese name for Jetavana is Gion Shōja, and so the most famous opening line in Japanese literature, the bell of Gion Shōja at the start of the Tale of the Heike, rings from the monastery Anāthapiṇḍika bought.

Hilo, Hawaii

Hilo, 1946

On April 1, 1946, an earthquake off the Aleutian Islands sent a tsunami across the Pacific. It struck Hilo a little after seven in the morning; many people took the first warnings for an April Fool's joke, and some went down to look at the drained bay before the larger waves came. The waves killed 159 people in the islands, 96 of them in Hilo, and at Laupāhoehoe the wave swept away schoolchildren and teachers. The bayfront and the railroad were wrecked and the Japanese neighborhood of Shinmachi was largely destroyed; it was rebuilt, and destroyed again in 1960. The disaster led to the first Pacific tsunami warning system. Most of Hawaii's Chinese families trace their roots to Zhongshan (Heungshan) in Guangdong.

Five months later, on September 1, the ILWU led about 26,000 workers out on the Hawaiian sugar strike of 1946, closing 33 of 34 plantations. Strikers fed themselves through soup kitchens, hunting and fishing parties, and committees that asked stores for donations. The settlement in November brought a raise of up to nineteen cents an hour and ended the perquisite system of company housing and services in lieu of wages. Haruo's regiment, the Japanese American 442nd, fought in the Vosges in October 1944; blinded veterans trained at Old Farms Convalescent Hospital in Avon, Connecticut from 1944 to 1947.

After the story of Anāthapiṇḍika from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 119 and 120). The original. Scripture from the Yi King, tr. James Legge (1882), and the Heike Monogatari, tr. A. L. Sadler (1918). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

9.5

A Trace

> *...in the vocabulary of nature, little and great are terms of comparison only; she knows no trifles...*
> *— George Perkins Marsh, Man and Nature (1864)*

The way the guards tell it, at the top of Brush Creek.

I. The Furniture

Highview Swim Club, Johnson County, Kansas · summer 1977

Highview was a members' pool on the hill off Lamar Avenue, where Overland Park runs into Prairie Village and nobody but the mailman knows which is which. Two hundred and eighty families owned it in equal shares. It had six lanes, a diving well, a baby pool, a snack window that sold frozen Snickers, and a board of seven that met on the second Tuesday in somebody's family room. In May the board had bought thirty new chaise lounges, aluminum with yellow vinyl straps, to go with the thirty old white ones. It had voted, after discussion, to keep the two pine picnic tables a member had donated in 1969.

Kim Hadley was head guard that summer. She was seventeen and would be a senior at Shawnee Mission East, and it was her third year on the stand. She was good at it. She did not twirl her whistle or talk to boys through the fence. She sat forward with her elbows on her knees and counted heads, shallow to deep and back, all day. The July before, she had gone off the stand in her sunglasses and brought a four-year-old up from the bottom of the five-foot before his mother finished turning around. She backwashed the filter when the dial said to. She took the chlorine and the pH every two hours and wrote them on the clipboard. At nine she locked the chemical room and the gate, and then tried the gate.

The last line on the closing list said FURNITURE STACKED UNDER PAVILION, and that one she did not do.

Whatever had been used out on the deck stayed out on the deck. The chaises the mothers had dragged onto the grass to follow the shade stayed on the grass, where the sprinklers came on at four in the morning. The umbrellas stayed up. In June a thunderstorm came over from Olathe at suppertime, put two chaises in the deep end and turned an umbrella inside out. By the Fourth the yellow straps along the west fence had gone the color of old piano keys and begun to split where they wrapped the frame. One of the pine tables had stood on the lawn since Memorial Day. It leaned when you sat at it, and when Doug Petrie turned it over, the legs were soft and the termites were in them.

The other guards said something. They were the ones who got pinched when a strap let go.

Kim. The chairs.

It's lawn furniture, Kim said. *Nobody ever drowned on a chaise. It's not worth the heartburn.*

We're supposed to stack them.

So I did one little thing wrong. Write it on the clipboard.

The next night she tried the gate twice and left sixty chaises out under the sky.

II. The Gauge

A Thursday in late July

Mr. Ordway was president of the board that year, having missed the meeting where it was decided. He was fifty-four, a long quiet man from Vermont with a daughter on the swim team. He did hydrology for the Corps of Engineers downtown, which the guards understood to mean that he was paid to know how high creeks got.

He came through the gate at seven every morning of the year, winter and summer, on his way to work. He came for the rain gauge. It stood on a post in the corner of the fence behind the pump house, a galvanized can eight inches across and twenty tall, open at the top. He was what the

Weather Service called a cooperative observer. The gauge had stood in his own back yard until his maples grew out over it, and the pool had the only open sky left on the hill, so the board had let him move it. Every morning he lifted off the funnel, drew out the narrow brass tube inside, put a thin stick down it, looked at the stick, and wrote in a book.

The guards told him about the furniture. Doug Petrie did it, at the gate, on a Thursday, and Mr. Ordway walked around the pump house to where Kim was hosing the deck for swim practice.

Kim. Is it so, what I hear about the chaises?

It's a little thing, Mr. Ordway, she said. *I get the gate and the chemicals and the water. Those are lawn chairs. It isn't worth anybody's heartburn.*

He did not tell her it was. He bent and pressed a yellow strap with his thumb, and it cracked along the fold.

Come hold the funnel for me, he said.

There had been a little weather in the night, nothing anybody woke for. She held the funnel. He drew the tube, put the stick down it and showed her. The wood was dark at the very tip, short of the first line.

What do you call that?

Nothing.

It's a trace. Too little to measure. You write a T. He wrote a T. *You always write it.*

Why, if you can't measure it?

Because it fell.

He turned the book back for her, a page to a month. The column for June was mostly T's and zeros, with a .02 and a .11, and one day near the end that said 1.34. He had kept it nineteen years. He said the county got a little over a yard of water a year, that nearly all of it came into that can a few hundredths of an inch at a time, and that he had never once been able to say which hundredth did anything.

An index card was taped inside the cover of the book, typed, brown at the edges. He put his finger beside it, and she read it standing there in her suit with the hose running.

> *It is a legal maxim that "the law concerneth not itself with trifles," de minimus non curat lex; but in the vocabulary of nature, little and great are terms of comparison only; she knows no trifles, and her laws are as inflexible in dealing with an atom as with a continent or a planet.*
>
> *...we are never justified in assuming a force to be insignificant because its measure is unknown...*
>
> *— George Perkins Marsh, Man and Nature (1864)*

He was from my town, Mr. Ordway said. *A good hundred years ahead of me. He's the one who worked out what happens to a river when you cut the trees off a hill.* He set the funnel back on the can. *The can doesn't know a little rain from a big one. It keeps what falls in it, that's all, and one morning it's full. A person fills the same way. You leave those out one night and that's a T. I couldn't measure it. But it's the same two hands that try the gate, and every night at nine they're being taught what they can walk past.*

I always try the gate.

I know you do. I've watched you.

She looked down the row of chaises. *It's not like weather matters up here,* she said. *We're on top of the hill. It all runs off. It never comes to us.*

Runs off where?

She did not know.

That ditch behind the baby pool is Brush Creek. That's where it starts. This parking lot is the first acre of it. What falls on this hill and can't soak in goes down that ditch, under Seventy-fifth Street, through Mission Hills and out across the Plaza. It all goes somewhere, Kim.

That was all he said. He went to work.

On Saturday there was a new card on the door of the guard shack, typed on the same machine as the one in the book. It was tacked above the closing list, where nobody could read the list without reading the card first.

All furniture stacked and chained under the pavilion at close. A guard who leaves it out is in the wrong. — L. O., for the Board

Kim stacked them that night, sixty chaises in six stacks of ten and the chairs in fours, ran the chain through, and then tried the gate. It took her

eleven minutes. She did it every night after that, through Labor Day. The guard shack roof had a leak over the desk that nobody had ever fixed, one drop every little while into a coffee can. In August she started emptying the can.

III. The Can

Tuesday, September 13, 1977

The pool closed on Labor Day. Kim's last act as head guard was to chain the furniture under the pavilion for the winter and hang the key on its nail.

A week later, a little after one on Monday morning, it began to rain on Kansas City and kept on until six. The afternoon was sunny. In the evening people went out to dinner on the Plaza. Around eight it began again, on ground that could not hold another cupful, and rained until two.

On Tuesday she drove over at a quarter to seven, as she had all summer. She could not have said why, except that she knew he would be there.

Lamar looked like a creek bed. Gravel lay across it in bars, with a doghouse, and somebody's mailbox still on its post. The club's parking lot had been scoured in a fan pointing downhill. At the low corner by the baby pool the chain-link lay flat, and woven into it was a hedge of other people's things: trash cans, a Big Wheel, a redwood planter, and lawn chairs from the yards up the street. There were eleven chairs. She counted them without meaning to. The pool was the color of coffee with milk in it. A line of silt crossed the deck and stood a hand high on the pavilion posts. Under the pavilion roof were six stacks of ten and the chairs in fours, muddy at the feet, chained, every one of them there.

Mr. Ordway was at the gauge. He had been at the District office since Monday noon and had on yesterday's shirt. He said nothing about the furniture. He held out the funnel, and she took it.

The brass tube was full to the lip, which was two inches. He read it and poured it on the ground. Then he lifted the big can off its post with both hands, and it was heavy. He poured from it through the funnel she

held until the tube was full again, read that, emptied it, and poured again. They went on until the can was dry. He did the adding twice in the margin.

Then he gave her the pencil.

Downstream the creek had gone through the Plaza five feet deep with cars in it. Twenty-five people were dead, though nobody at Highview knew the number yet. All Kim knew was the page. September ran down it in his small upright hand: T, 0, 0, T, .04, T, 0. Then came Monday's line, which was his, and under it Tuesday's, which was empty.

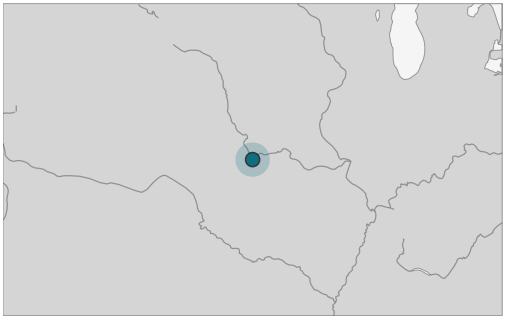
She wrote the number. It took up one line, the same as a T.

Background

The verse

> *Let no man think lightly of evil, saying in his heart, It will not come nigh unto me. Even by the falling of water-drops a water-pot is filled; the fool becomes full of evil, even if he gather it little by little.*
>
> Dhammapada 121, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary's story is short. A monk leaves outdoors whatever beds and chairs of the community he has used outdoors, and rain, sun and white ants ruin them. When the other monks say he ought to put things away, he answers that it is a slight fault, not worth wasting thought or bile over, and does it again. They tell the Buddha, who sends for him and asks whether it is true, and the monk gives him the same answer. The Buddha says that no one should call a wrong deed a trifle: a jar left open in the rain is not filled by one drop, but it fills. He speaks the verse and lays down a rule that a monk who leaves a bed out in the open is at fault. Read the full commentary story.



Overland Park, Kansas

Brush Creek, 1977

Brush Creek rises near West 80th Street and Lamar Avenue in Overland Park, Kansas, runs through Prairie Village and Mission Hills, and crosses into Kansas City, Missouri, at the Country Club Plaza. On September 12, 1977, two storms struck the city within one day, the first from about 1 to 6 a.m. and the second from about 8 p.m. to 2 a.m., with sunshine in between. As much as sixteen inches fell. The first rain saturated the ground and the second ran off it. The U.S. Geological Survey's report counts twenty-five dead and notes that even people living on slopes above the flood plains had hillside runoff in their garages and basements. At 75th Street and Nall Avenue in Prairie Village, where the creek has gathered only a mile and a half of suburb, the Survey estimated a peak of 3,000 cubic feet a second, well past the hundred-year flood. Downstream the water stood five to six feet deep on the Plaza. The Corps of Engineers had warned in 1970 that the creek could reach flood stage in under an hour; the Kansas City Public Library tells the story. Highview, its board, Mr. Ordway and Kim Hadley are invented.

The National Weather Service's Cooperative Observer Program, begun in 1890, relies on thousands of volunteers who read their instruments once a day. The standard rain gauge is an eight-inch funnel over a narrow measuring tube inside a can twenty inches tall; the tube holds two inches, and whatever overflows into the can is poured back through and measured. Rain too slight to measure is entered as a trace, written T. George Perkins Marsh was born in Woodstock, Vermont, in 1801. His *Man and Nature* (1864) argued, from the ruined hillsides of the Mediterranean and the cut-over ones of New England, that human beings change the earth by small acts added together, and it helped to launch the conservation movement. The words on the index card are from its last section, which Marsh headed "Nothing Small in Nature." The Latin is spelled as he printed it.

After the story of the monk who would not put away his requisites, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 121). The original. The teaching text is George Perkins Marsh, Man and Nature (1864). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.6

Three Fingers

Little drops of water,
Little grains of sand,
Make the mighty ocean
And the pleasant land.
— Julia A. Carney, "Little Things" (1845)

Comme on m'a dit, along Highway 90.

I. The Pot

Rougeau, Jefferson Davis Parish, Louisiana · August 27 to September 2, 2020

Laura came ashore at Cameron at one in the morning on a Thursday, and by daylight the town of Rougeau had no roof that was whole. Rougeau was eleven hundred people on Highway 90 in the rice country east of Lake Charles, with a water tower, a Catholic church, and a rice dryer whose bins could be seen for six miles. The poles were down the length of the highway. The water went off that afternoon. It was ninety-four degrees, and the power company was talking about weeks.

Curtis Ledet drove a school bus for the parish and had been an usher at Sacred Heart for thirty years. He and his wife Loretta rode it out in the hall closet with her mother's rosary. When they came out there was sky over the back bedroom. He got a blue tarp on it by Friday, but a tarp will leak at a nail, and this one leaked over the kitchen, a drop about every four seconds. Loretta set her big aluminum gumbo pot under it. It did not look like anything. In the morning the pot was full to the rim, and they flushed the toilet with it and set it back.

On Sunday the trucks came. There were fourteen of them, pulling trailers with black iron pots on them the size of washtubs, and propane

burners, and paddles like boat oars. The man in the first truck was Marcus Papillion of Opelousas, thirty-three years old, who until April had been a galley hand on a production platform a hundred miles out in the Gulf. Oil had gone below nothing that month and they laid off his whole hitch. He had gone home, set a telephone on a tripod in his mother's yard, and started cooking for it. He hardly talked in the videos. A person watching saw the pot, the roux going from the color of peanut butter to the color of a penny, and his forearms, and at the end he would look up and say what it was and who it was for. By August three hundred thousand people were watching him do that. When he said he was taking the pots to Lake Charles, forty of them got in their trucks and came along, from Lafayette and Houston and as far as Mobile. Nobody had sent for them. People in Rougeau said afterward that they seemed to come up out of the ground.

They set up in the lot beside the church hall and fed the town twice a day. They fed the linemen too, crews from Oklahoma and Indiana who had been sleeping in their trucks. Rougeau was their sixth town in a week. In the evenings, when the pots were scrubbed, Marcus sat on a tailgate and went live for ten minutes to give thanks. He read out the names of people who had sent money, every one, the five-dollar ones the same as the five-hundred.

On the Wednesday, Curtis was standing behind the truck when he did it. Marcus finished the names. Then he said something else, which was more than he usually said.

I been watching this page four months, he said to the telephone. *I see four kinds of people on it. Some of y'all send, and don't share it with nobody. You going to have plenty, and you going to eat it by yourself. Some of y'all share and share, and never send a dollar. You going to have a big crowd around you someday and nothing in the pot for them. Some don't send and don't share. Y'all going to be eating off what's left on somebody else's plate. And some of y'all give, and then go get somebody else to give. Them ones get it both ways. They get the plenty, and the people to eat it with.* He looked up. *That's all. Red beans tomorrow.*

Curtis stood there after the light on the telephone went off. Then he walked around the tailgate.

Mr. Papillion. Tomorrow you don't cook. Friday either. Friday y'all sit down and we feed you.

Marcus looked at him, and at the town behind him with the tarps on it.

How many of us you want?

All y'all. Every one that came.

That's forty-three.

I counted, Curtis said.

II. The Wagon

Rougeau · Thursday, September 3

He started at seven, with his grandson's wagon. In the wagon he had a five-gallon bucket for dry goods, an ice chest, and a spiral notebook. He went to every door in Rougeau that still had one, and where there was no door he called into the yard.

Mama, Daddy, he said at each place, the way an usher talks. *I asked the cooks to supper tomorrow, all of them. Give what you can spare. Rice, beans, whatever you got that'll go in a pot. We'll cook it all in one place, at the hall, and it'll be from everybody.*

Nobody in that town had much that week, and most of it was thawing. They gave it. Mrs. Guillory gave him four pounds of smoked sausage out of a freezer that had been dead a week and packed in ice from the relief truck. He got onions and bell pepper from one house and a sack of rice with the top rolled down from the next. He got two pounds of red beans, half a bottle of oil, and a jar of cane syrup from Abbeville. A woman who had moved over from Iberia Parish gave him three jars of pepper paste that her Lao neighbors there had taught her to put up. A man with nothing in his house but a case of water gave the water. Curtis wrote each name in the notebook and what it was. By ten the wagon had been home twice to unload.

Trahan's Dryer and Feed stood on the highway at the east end of town. Vernon Trahan was sixty-seven. He had four million pounds of other men's rough rice in his bins, drying, and he had kept the fans turning on it since Thursday with a diesel generator the size of a van. Inside the store, milled rice in twenty-five-pound sacks was stacked to the rafters by the door. Behind the office was a room he called the hurricane room. He had begun stocking it the week after Rita in 2005, and he had told no one what was in it. There was enough in it to feed his family a year.

He was not a hard man in the usual way. He had carried half the farmers in the parish through one bad year or another. But he held it for a principle that a person should promise what he could deliver out of his own pocket and no more. He saw Curtis Ledet coming along the highway with a child's wagon and he knew what it was about. The whole town knew by then.

There's a man, he said to his yard hand, *who invited forty-three people to supper and hasn't got forty-three plates. So now he goes door to door writing checks on everybody else's account. If he wanted to feed five, he ought to have asked five.*

Curtis stopped in the door of the store and said his piece.

Bring your bucket here, Vernon said.

He slit a sack with his pocketknife. He put in his thumb and two fingers, as a man takes snuff, and brought out what they would hold, and dropped it in the bucket. It was perhaps forty grains. He did the same from a sack of red beans. Then he took a coffee can off the counter and set it down inside the bucket, so it filled one side, and into the corner that was left he tipped a jug of cooking oil until a thread ran, and stopped it. He had a box of sugar cubes for the coffee. He dropped in three of them, one at a time.

There you go, he said.

Thank you, Mr. Vernon, Curtis said. He wrote it in the notebook. Then he took a clean handkerchief out of his back pocket and lifted Vernon's rice, beans and sugar out of the bucket into it. He tied the corners and put it in his shirt pocket by itself. The oil he poured off into the cap of his water bottle and carried in his hand.

Vernon watched him go down the highway that way, pulling the wagon with one hand and holding the bottle cap level in the other.

Now why did he put mine separate? he said. Nobody answered him. The yard hand was a boy named Dustin, and Vernon turned to him. *Go on up to the hall tonight and see what he does with it.*

By noon it was all over Rougeau, the thumb and the two fingers. They called him Trois-Doigts before the day was out, Three Fingers, and he carried the name for the rest of his life.

III. The Spoon

The church hall · that night

THEY COOKED IN THE YARD OF THE HALL ON THE KREWE'S OWN burners, which Marcus lent and would not touch. He sat in a lawn chair with his hands on his knees, the first evening in three weeks that he had not held a paddle. Loretta Ledet had the jambalaya. There was a pot of red beans, a pot of white beans with the sausage, a rice dressing, a pot of plain rice, and a dishpan of bread pudding going into the hall oven, which ran on bottled gas.

Dustin stood by the fence and watched.

When the pots were all on, Curtis took the handkerchief out of his shirt pocket and untied it on the table. He counted the rice into six small heaps with the tip of a teaspoon. He went to each pot and put in its heap, six or seven grains, and into the two bean pots he put the red beans, a few to each. He had the oil in the bottle cap still. He let one drop of it fall from the spoon into every pot. The sugar cubes went into the bread pudding. At each pot he said the same thing, quietly, as he would have said a response at Mass.

May Mr. Vernon get it back full.

Loretta asked him what in the world he was doing.

He gave, Curtis said. *If I dump his in with the rest, it's only in the one pot. I want him in every plate.*

Dustin went back down the highway and told it exactly.

Vernon Trahan did not sleep. He sat in the office with the generator running outside and went over it. He did not believe the blessing. He believed he was being set up. Tomorrow the whole town would be in that yard, and the cooks with their telephones, and three hundred thousand people behind the telephones. The usher would stand up and thank everyone by name out of that notebook, as the cook did every night. He would come to the T's. *Vernon Trahan, who has rice to the rafters, gave what a man can pick up with three fingers.* Then every soul in the parish would know what he was. And they would start to wonder what else he had back there, with the stores empty from here to Lafayette.

Toward morning he opened the desk drawer and took out the .38 he kept for the night deposit. He looked at it for a while. *If he calls my name to shame me,* he said to himself, *I will shoot him where he stands.* He was horrified to hear himself think it, and he put the pistol in his waistband under his shirt all the same.

IV. The Hall

Friday, September 4

They ate at five, when the yard was in shade. The krewe sat down at the long tables, forty-three of them, in masks pulled under their chins, looking as if they did not know what to do with their hands. The linemen sat down. The town stood and served them. Vernon Trahan stood at the back, by the fence, with his shirt out.

When everyone had a plate, Curtis got up on the hall steps with the notebook. Marcus Papillion had set his telephone on its tripod and turned it around to face the steps.

Mr. Papillion, Curtis said. *You and your people been feeding us five days. Tonight this is from Rougeau. I went around and asked, and everybody I asked gave something. They gave what they could. Some of them gave by the sack and some gave by the pinch.* He did not open the notebook. *I'm not going to read no names. It's all in the pots together now, and I couldn't tell you whose is whose. May every one of them that gave get it back full. That's all. Y'all eat.*

He came down the steps.

Vernon had his hand flat against his shirt. He stood a moment longer. He said afterward that he had come there ready to kill a man for something the man had never meant to do. He said he had understood, standing by that fence, that if he walked away from it without a word, he would deserve whatever fell on him and his bins.

He came up through the tables. People saw his face and made room. He stopped in front of Curtis Ledet and got down on both knees in the shell gravel, a heavy man of sixty-seven.

Curtis. Forgive me.

For what, Mr. Vernon? Get up.

Vernon did not get up. He told it from there, all of it, loud enough for the tables. He told about the three fingers and the coffee can in the bucket, and about sending the boy to spy. He told what he had sat up thinking. He reached under his shirt, and took out the .38, and laid it on the gravel between them.

Nobody moved. Then Marcus got out of his chair and came over. He looked at the pistol, and at the man kneeling, and at Curtis.

What's this about?

Curtis told him, from Thursday morning on. He told it plainly and did not make it worse.

That right, sir? Marcus said.

That's right, said Vernon. *Every bit.*

V. Little Things

The same evening

MARCUS PICKED THE PISTOL UP BY THE BARREL, BROKE IT open, and shook the shells out into his hand. He gave the shells to Vernon and the pistol to a deputy who was eating at the second table.

Get up, Mr. Trahan, he said. *You wrong about one thing still. You think what you gave was nothing.*

He helped him up by the elbow.

It wasn't nothing. I ate it. It was in the jambalaya and it was in the beans. He turned a little, so that he was speaking to the tables as well, and to the

telephone on its tripod, though he seemed to have forgotten it. *Don't none of y'all look down on a little bit of good and say it won't ever amount to nothing, it won't ever come back around to me. My maw-maw used to tell us* petit à petit, l'oiseau fait son nid. *Little by little the bird builds her nest. Mr. Curtis told me they got a pot at his house under a leak in the roof. One drop. You wouldn't cross the room for it. In the morning they can't lift the pot. A person with sense fills up the same way, a pinch at a time. So don't call it a pinch.*

That was all he said. He went back to his plate.

There was an old woman at the end of the first table, Miss Odile Citizen, ninety-one, who had been taught as a child in Lafayette by the Sisters of the Holy Family, before the war. She had not followed all of it. She had heard the part about the drop. She began to sing, in a high cracked voice, what the Sisters had made the first grade sing with their hands folded on the desks, and the tables went quiet for her.

Little drops of water,
Little grains of sand,
Make the mighty ocean
And the pleasant land.

Little deeds of kindness,
Little words of love,
Help to make earth happy
Like the heaven above.

— Julia A. Carney, "Little Things" (1845)

Vernon Trahan ate standing up, a full plate, and looked at each forkful before he put it in his mouth. Then he went and got his truck. He came back with the bed loaded. He had twelve sacks of rice and six of beans, four cases of oil, and the whole box of sugar. The krewe was leaving for DeQuincy in the morning, and he put it on the first trailer himself and would not be helped. Afterward he ran three hundred feet of cord from the dryer's generator to the hall, so that the freezer in the kitchen ran that night for the first time in nine days. The hurricane room he opened

on Monday. People who were let into it said he stood in the door calling out what was on each shelf, like a man reading a will.

They went on calling him Three Fingers. He answered to it, and after a year or so he signed it on the dryer's Christmas card.

It rained that Friday night, late, a plain rain off the Gulf with no wind in it. Curtis woke and heard the tarp. He got up in the dark and went to the kitchen. Loretta's pot was on the stove where she had left it after washing. He carried it over and set it down under the nail, and listened to the first drop strike the bottom.

Background

The verse

> *Let no man think lightly of good, saying in his heart, It will not come nigh unto me. Even by the falling of water-drops a water-pot is filled; the wise man becomes full of good, even if he gather it little by little.*
>
> Dhammapada 122, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha thanks the people of Sāvatthī for a meal by describing four kinds of people: the one who gives but does not urge others, who will have wealth without a following; the one who urges but does not give, who will have a following without wealth; the one who does neither, who will live on leftovers; and the one who does both and has both. A layman who hears this invites the Buddha and all his monks for the next day and goes through the town asking each household for rice and whatever else it can spare, to be cooked in one place. A rich merchant, angry that the man has invited more than he can feed himself, gives him rice and beans pinched up in three fingers and dribbles out oil and sugar; from that day he is called Biḷālapādaka, Cat's Foot, after a tiny measure. The layman keeps the merchant's gift apart, and the merchant sends a servant to watch, who sees him put a few grains and drops into every pot with a blessing. Sure that he will be shamed by name, the merchant comes to the meal with a knife hidden in his clothes. The layman blesses all the givers alike. The merchant falls at his feet and confesses, and the Buddha says that no good deed should be called a trifle. Read the full commentary story.

Jefferson Davis Parish, Louisiana

Southwest Louisiana, 2020

Hurricane Laura made landfall at Cameron, Louisiana, about one in the morning on August 27, 2020, as a Category 4 storm, tied for the strongest landfall in the state's record. It wrecked Lake Charles and the rice parishes to the east, brought down the transmission lines that fed the region, and left some two hundred thousand people without drinking water; power in places was out for weeks, and six weeks later Hurricane Delta came ashore twelve miles away. In Jefferson Davis Parish, Entergy described crews cutting trees off the lines and setting new poles along Highway 101. Most of the first rice crop was already cut, and growers kept their bins and dryers going on generators. The same country had been hit by Hurricane Rita in 2005. Volunteer cooks with trailers of cast-iron pots, many of them organized online, fed storm towns across the region that fall.

It was also the first year of the pandemic. On April 20, 2020, the price of American crude fell below zero for the first time, and offshore crews along the Gulf were laid off by the hitch. The prairie parishes of southwest Louisiana are Cajun and Creole, largely Catholic, and many older people still have French; *petit à petit, l'oiseau fait son nid* is an old French proverb. The Sisters of the Holy Family, a congregation of Black Catholic women founded in New Orleans in 1842, taught in Lafayette from 1913. "Little Things" was written by Julia A. Carney in Boston in 1845 and sung by schoolchildren for a century afterward; its last stanza was added in later printings. Rougeau and everyone in it are invented.

After the story of the rich man Biḷālapādaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 122). The original. Verse from "Little Things" by Julia A. Carney (1845). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.7

Grindstone Ford

I find the Traces of abundance of Feet going into your Majesty's Palace, and not one that comes back again.
— Aesop, A Fox and a Sick Lion, tr. Sir Roger L'Estrange (1692)

The way I had it told to me, on the Natchez road.

I. The Notice

Natchez Under-the-Hill, Mississippi Territory · May 1803

MAYHEW DANE CAME DOWN FROM PITTSBURGH THAT SPRING with five broadhorns of flour, whiskey and bar iron. By the first week of May he had sold all of it at Natchez, and the boats too, for their lumber. What he had to show for the winter was Spanish dollars, in four small kegs with NAILS painted on the heads. Everybody under the hill knew what was in the kegs. A man can't sell five boatloads in a town that size and keep it quiet.

Twice in one week somebody tried the storehouse he had hired by the landing. The second time they brought an auger, and they had three holes through the planking before the watchman's dog made up its mind to bark. Dane sat on the kegs the rest of that night with a horse pistol across his knees. In the morning he wrote out a notice and had it nailed up at the post office on the bluff and at two of the grog shops below.

Mr. Dane of Pittsburgh starts for Nashville by the Natchez road on Monday. Any men of the upper country going home that way may travel with his wagon. They will not want for bread or meat while they are with him.

There were plenty to read it. The boats came down the river every spring and none of them went back. The men who had steered them walked home, five hundred miles up through the Choctaw and Chickas-

aw nations to the Tennessee and on to the Cumberland, and a good many left Natchez with nothing in their pockets but their hands. Absalom Leeper was one of those. He was twenty-two, from Redstone on the Monongahela. He had been paid forty dollars at the landing and could account for about six of them. Eleven others in the same case put their names or their marks under his.

Dane looked them over from the storehouse door. He was a short, careful man with ink on his cuff, and he counted them twice.

Twelve, he said. *I had hoped for forty. Well, twelve eat less.*

They went out on Monday at daylight behind an ox wagon, with the four kegs under the meal sacks. Some others who had read the notice, and had no thought of walking home, were gone from Natchez the night before.

II. The Ford

Grindstone Ford on Bayou Pierre

Seventy miles north of Natchez the road came down to Bayou Pierre at a place called Grindstone Ford, and there the settled country stopped. South of the bayou were cotton fields and cabins and such law as the Territory had. North of it lay the Choctaw nation. The road from there was a horse path through cane and big timber, with days between one roof and the next.

There was a stand at the ford, a log house of one room where a traveler could buy mush and milk and a place on the floor. A wagon could go no farther. Dane stopped three days to sell the wagon and the oxen and buy pack horses, and he was particular about horses. The twelve lay about the yard and ate. He had been as good as his notice. There was meal and bacon twice a day and coffee in the morning, and Leeper, who had not eaten twice a day since March, began to fill out his shirt again.

The stand kept a hired man named Luke Farrow, who worked the canoe when the bayou was up and saw to the stock. On the second evening somebody hallooed from the cane on the north bank to be fetched across, and Luke knew the voice before he knew the man. It was Wiley Harkins.

The two of them had poled a keelboat up the Cumberland four summers before, and Harkins had once pulled him out of that river by the hair.

Harkins did not want supper. He stood by the canoe and looked up at the yard.

When's the Pittsburgh man going on?

Day after tomorrow, I heard him say. What is it to you?

Harkins told him. He never had been able to hold a thing in. There were men camped a day up the path where it crossed a creek, he said, more men than Luke would guess, and some of them had been with Mason or said they had. They had tried a plank wall in Natchez twice. They did not mean to try it again when the kegs were coming up to them on horses.

Well, Luke said. *He will be along directly. Go on back.*

He set Harkins across and pulled the canoe up and stood by it a while. He owed Harkins something. He owed the Pittsburgh man nothing at all. Dane had not said ten words to him in two days, and had counted his change. Still it came to him that he could stop one side or the other of this, and that he had better pick. He looked up at the yard. Twelve men sat around Dane's kettle with Dane's bacon in their fingers, and one of them was singing. Luke thought of the same twelve somewhere up in the cane with no kettle.

What have I to do with thieves, he thought, and went to find Dane.

Dane heard him out, standing by a horse with its near forefoot in his hand.

How do you know it?

I know one of them. He told me.

Dane put the hoof down. He did not thank Luke and he did not doubt him.

Then I have no business going on at all, he said. *I will turn round and go home by New Orleans and the sea.*

III. Neither Way

The same place · that week and the next

Horses are sooner bought than sold, and Dane was still at the ford when Harkins hallooed again. Luke told him the plain truth. The Pittsburgh man had given up the path and meant to go back down to Natchez. Harkins went off with that. Inside of two days the men had come out of the cane, crossed the bayou above the ford in the night, and laid up along the Natchez road, where it ran sunk between high clay banks a few miles to the south.

Dane still had not gone. Harkins came a third time, and this time he came riding up from the south like any other traveler. Luke understood from that where they were lying now. He told Dane that too.

Dane sat on one of his kegs in the yard a good part of that afternoon. He looked at the bayou and the spring above it. He looked at the corn standing behind the house, and at the ford, where every man going up or down the country had to wet his feet. Three parties came through while he sat there. One wanted powder and one wanted shoes, and the stand had neither to sell.

I want for nothing here, he said, to nobody. *I will go neither up nor back. I will stop where I am.*

He went over to the twelve.

There were men laid for me up the path. When I thought to turn back they shifted and laid for me down the road. So I am going neither way. Any of you that wants to stop here with me may, and I will find him work. Any that wants to go on, go, and take a week's meal with you.

They talked it over. They were men with people up the country and corn that somebody else was hoeing. In the morning they took the meal and thanked him and waded the bayou. Each of them carried everything he owned, which was a blanket and whatever stick he had cut for himself, and they went up into the cane in a line.

On the second day the path crossed a creek, and by it they found the ashes of a good many fires and nobody at all. A week after that, two men sitting their horses beside the path looked each one of them over as he

came by. One of the two laughed. Nothing else happened to them the whole way.

IV. The Mail

Colbert's ferry on the Tennessee · June

The mail between Nashville and Natchez went that year by one man on one horse. He had a pair of leather bags behind the saddle, a blanket, a sack of corn, and a tin trumpet to blow when he came near a house. The rider that summer was Josiah Vance. He had carried it since the road was made a post road, and had ridden express in Pennsylvania as a boy before that. He read everything that was nailed up at either end of his route. He had read Dane's notice in Natchez. Going north, he had passed the ford while Dane was trading for horses, and had seen the twelve in the yard.

He met them again a fortnight later, coming south, at the Tennessee River, where the Colberts, who were Chickasaw, kept the ferry. The twelve were sitting on the south bank waiting for the boat. Their meal had run out in the second week and they were gaunt again. Vance led his horse off the ferry and stopped in front of them.

You are Dane's men. Where is Dane?

Leeper told him all of it, the men up the path and the men down the road, and Dane sitting on his keg.

He is building himself a store, Leeper said. *We came on.*

And nobody troubled you.

They looked at us.

Vance let the horse drink. He was a man who had whole days to think in, and he did not hurry over it.

I ride through those men twice a month, he said. *They have walked out of the cane and asked me the news as civil as deacons. They have never laid a hand on these bags. It is paper, and they cannot spend it. You went through the same way, with nothing on you. Dane has what they want and one pair of hands to keep it with. He knows that, so he stays off that road. He does not go a little way up it to see.*

Then he told them about the lion. His mother had owned one book besides the Bible, he said, and it was the Fables. The lion in it was too old to hunt, so he lay down in his cave and gave out that he was sick. The beasts came one at a time to ask after him. The fox came last and stood well outside and wished him better. *Why do you not come in?* said the lion, and the fox said he had been looking at the ground.

> *I find the Traces of abundance of Feet going into your Majesty's Palace, and not one that comes back again.*
>
> *— Aesop, A Fox and a Sick Lion, tr. L'Estrange*

Now, said Vance. *You will get home, and next spring you will come down the river and be paid again. The cards will be there under the hill, and the women, and the whiskey, the same as this year. You know that ground. You have seen whose tracks go in. There is something laid up beside any road a man goes down wanting. Keep off the wrong ones the way Dane keeps off this one. None of you would eat jimson seed to find out if what they say about it is so.*

That is hard talk to a man with six dollars, somebody said.

You had forty, said Vance.

He got up on the horse and blew the trumpet once for the Colberts' people on the far side, out of habit, and rode up the south bank the way they had come.

. . .

Absalom Leeper came down the river again the next spring, steering for a man from Wheeling. He was paid at the landing. He walked up the bluff with the forty dollars past every door under the hill, and it is told of him that he counted the doors.

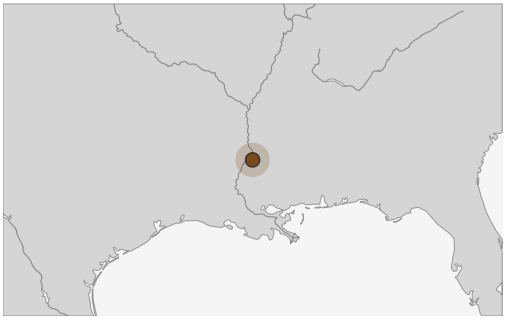
At Grindstone Ford there was a store with a shingle roof and a counter made of wagon boards. He bought a pair of shoes there and paid in hard money. Mayhew Dane counted out his change, and then counted it again. Leeper went down to the water and crossed. In the mud on the north side were the tracks of the men ahead of him, all pointing one way. Over them, coming down to the ford, lay the print of one shod horse.

Background

The verse

> *Let a man avoid evil deeds, as a merchant, if he has few companions and carries much wealth, avoids a dangerous road; as a man who loves life avoids poison.*
>
> Dhammapada 123, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred thieves fail to break into the house of the merchant Mahā Dhana ("Great Wealth"). When he sets out with five hundred carts, he invites five hundred monks to travel with him and promises them food on the way. The thieves hide in a forest ahead. The merchant halts at a village at the forest's edge, and the thieves' scout asks a friend in the village when the merchant will leave. The friend decides to warn the merchant, because the monks are living on his bounty. The merchant resolves to turn back; the thieves move to the road behind him; warned again, he decides to go neither forward nor back and stays where he is. The monks return to the Buddha, who makes the merchant's prudence a lesson: avoid evil as he avoids that road, and as a man who wants to live avoids poison. Read the full commentary story.



Grindstone Ford, Mississippi Territory

The Natchez road, 1803

Before steamboats, farmers and merchants of the Ohio valley floated their produce down to Natchez and New Orleans on flatboats, sold the cargo and the boat, and walked or rode home. The way home was the Natchez Trace, some five hundred miles of path through the Choctaw and Chickasaw nations to Nashville. The boatmen were called Kaintucks wherever they came from. Grindstone Ford on Bayou Pierre marked the line between the Natchez District and the Choctaw nation; a plain stand there fed travelers on mush and milk. At the Tennessee River the Chickasaw Colbert family kept the ferry. Men going north carried their season's earnings in

coin, and robbers worked the road and the river. The best known, Samuel Mason, was killed in 1803. Everyone in this story is invented.

Congress made the Trace a post road in 1800. The mail went by single riders, who carried a blanket, corn for the horse and a tin trumpet. John Swaney, who rode the route in these years, remembered that Mason often stopped him to ask the news and told him no mail carrier need fear his men, since mail was of no value to them; the reminiscence is given in Otto Rothert's *The Outlaws of Cave-in-Rock* (1924). The first post office at Natchez opened in November 1799. The fable the rider tells is the old one of the fox and the sick lion, quoted here from Sir Roger L'Estrange's English Aesop of 1692, a version much reprinted in the century that followed.

After the story of the merchant Mahā Dhana from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 123). The original. The fable from Sir Roger L'Estrange's Aesop (1692). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.8

A Whole Hand

Evil into the mind of God or Man
May come and go, so unapprov'd, and leave
No spot or blame behind
— Milton, Paradise Lost V.117–119

They tell it this way in the Jersey Market.

I. The Window

High Street, Philadelphia · December 1821

Thomas Ashmead shipped flour to the West Indies and brought back sugar, and he had built his house on High Street above Front, four stories of brick with the counting room on the ground floor. He put his daughter at the top of it. Susanna was sixteen that winter. Her room looked down on the long roof of the Jersey Market, which ran up the middle of the street from Front to Second, and a serving woman named Hannah Schofield slept across her door.

Hannah was from Salford in Lancashire. She had come over in 1817 with the people who followed Mr. Metcalfe, the ones the city called Bible Christians, who signed a paper promising to eat no flesh and drink no spirits and who met on Sundays in Mr. Metcalfe's hired schoolroom behind North Front Street. The Ashmeads were Christ Church people and did not ask what Hannah did with her Sunday afternoons, or notice that for four years she had taken the child with her. Susanna had signed the paper herself at twelve. An old weaver named Abel Horrocks, whom the children of that meeting called Father Abel, had ruled the line for her name because she could not yet write straight. At her father's table she

passed the joint along and ate the bread and the greens, and her mother put it down to a girl's stomach.

On a Friday toward evening, with the lamps not yet lit, a Jersey wagon came off the ferry and up to the market. It was heaped with deer. There were nine or ten of them, frozen stiff with their legs every which way, and strings of partridge hung down the sides. The man driving sat forward on the tongue between his two horses with the lines loose in one hand. He was young and long in the leg, and he had on a coat made out of a blanket. He looked at nothing in the street. He seemed to be listening to the horses.

Susanna stood at the window until he had backed the wagon in under the shed. She said afterward that it was like seeing somebody from home. She had no other way to say it, and she had never lived anywhere but that house.

She gave Hannah a levy and sent her down for a brace of partridge for the kitchen, and told her to ask the man when he went back. Hannah thought it an odd errand for that particular girl. She went, because she was sent. The hunter took the coin and gave her the birds.

I will sell out tomorrow, he said, *and go down to the first boat Sunday morning. Who wants to know?*

The house, said Hannah, and carried it upstairs with the partridge.

II. The Ferry

The Market Street slip · Sunday, before light

SUSANNA LAID OUT WHAT SHE MEANT TO TAKE, AND IT WAS not much: two shifts, a pair of stockings, a garnet ring that had come to her from her grandmother, the pledge card. She tied them flat under an old brown gown of Hannah's that was waiting for the rag bag. Before anyone was up she went down the back stair with the kitchen pitcher in her hand, like a girl sent to the Jersey boats for buttermilk.

She stood on the slip in the cold. The wagon came down empty with the two horses blowing steam. When it went onto the boat she went on

behind it, and when it came off on the Jersey side and took the road east she walked in the track of its wheels.

He let it go on for a mile before he stopped the horses.

I do not know you, he said. *You are nobody's girl that I ever traded with. Leave off following me.*

You did not call me, said Susanna. *I came on my own feet. Mind your team.*

He drove on. He stopped twice more and told her to go back, and she stood in the road each time and waited for him to finish. The third time she looked at him directly.

When good fortune walks up behind a man, he has no call to send it home.

His name was Micah Cox. His grandfather had been a Hessian named Hahn who walked away from his regiment in 1778 and into the pines. Micah looked at the girl standing in the sand in a servant's gown with no bonnet. Then he got down and put his hands together for her foot and helped her up over the wheel.

Hannah found the pitcher on the slip that afternoon. The watermen dragged below the ferry for three days. In January the Ashmeads put up a stone in Christ Church ground that said *Susanna, drowned*, with the year, and gave the mourning rings, and Thomas Ashmead had the top room shut.

III. The Brush Fence

The Pines, on a branch of the Wading River · November 1849

In twenty-eight years she bore him seven sons, the last two together. They grew up tall and quiet like him. She got them all married before they were twenty-one, to girls from the furnace villages and the cedar swamps, and all seven couples lived within a shout of the old house. The Coxes were the best hunters in that country. They kept better than four hundred snares on six miles of brush fence for the partridge and the rabbits, and they drove the deer with hounds to where eight guns stood waiting. Every other week from frost to March a wagon went to Philadelphia.

Susanna ran the bullets. She did it at the kitchen fire with a ladle and a brass mould, and trimmed them with a knife, and counted them into the pouches. In the morning she handed down the long gun from its pegs, and the horn and the pouch after it, because he was her husband and he put his hand out. She salted and hung what was not sold. She had never once eaten of it. The girls her sons married thought that was strange for about a month, and then it was only how Mother Cox was.

Abel Horrocks was eighty-four that fall and still weaving check on a hand loom in Kensington. He woke one morning in the dark with fifteen people in his mind whom he had never seen. They were as plain to him as fifteen ends drawn through the reed. He lay still and asked himself what would come of it, and it seemed to him that all fifteen were ready. He got up and put on his clogs and took the ferry.

Nobody has explained how a man of that age came forty miles of sand road by the next daybreak. He walked the whole length of the Cox fence in the first gray light. There was a gap in the brush every few yards and a horsehair noose hung in every gap, and that morning not one noose had anything in it. At the last gap he stepped over. He left the print of one clog in the wet sand squarely under the snare, the wooden sole with its iron rim like a small horseshoe. Then he went and sat down under a holly bush forty yards off, in the lee of the wind.

IV. Eight Guns

The same morning

Micah came along the fence at sunup with the long gun on his arm and found four hundred snares hanging empty. In twenty-eight years that had never happened. At the last gap he found the print.

Somebody is walking my fence and letting out what I catch, he said.

He looked up and saw an old man sitting under the holly with his hands on his knees. Micah thumbed back the hammer and brought the gun to his shoulder. He meant to shoot. The old man let him get that far and no farther. Micah's finger would not close and his arms would not come down. He stood with the long gun leveled and could neither fire it

nor lower it. The barrel began to shake. The spit ran out of the corner of his mouth, and it felt to him as if every one of his ribs had been stove in.

At the house the sons said, *Father is a long time on the fence.* Their mother sent them to look. They came through the pines with their guns and saw him standing fixed, and saw what he was aiming at. They took the old man for some enemy of their father's. All seven threw up their guns, and all seven stayed just as they were. There were eight men in a row among the trees with eight guns leveled, and no sound but their breathing.

Then Susanna came with the seven young wives behind her. She saw the row of backs first, and she wondered who in that country they could all be aiming at. Then she looked past the muzzles. It had been twenty-eight years, and he had been old then.

Do not shoot! she cried, and ran in front of the guns with her arms out. *That is my father! Do not kill my father!*

Micah heard it. *Her father,* he thought. *Then that is my wife's father, that I never once saw, and I had a ball ready for him.* The sons thought, *Grandfather.* Something went out of all eight of them at the same moment, and the old man under the holly saw it go.

Put them down, said Susanna. *Put them on the ground and ask his pardon.*

He let them. The guns came down. One of the twins sat down in the sand like a child. They went over one by one with their hats off and said what she had told them to say, and then they sat in the pine needles in front of him, the eight men and the eight women, because nobody could think what else to do.

Abel Horrocks did not preach long. He had never been easy on his feet in front of people, and he stayed sitting. He said he had walked their fence. He said it was well made. He said a partridge puts her neck in the noose because she wants to go through the gap and get to the other side. *That is all she wants. It is all you wanted when you put the gun up. It is all anybody wants.* He said that was where a person began. Then he went on from there in order, one thing after the next, the way he would have threaded a loom. When he was done the fifteen who had never heard any of it before had got hold of something they did not afterward let go.

The sons drew the charges that same day. The long gun went back on its pegs and stayed there. By Christmas the noose had been cut out of every gap in six miles of fence, and the brush was left standing for the birds to go through.

V. Ratsbane

The Bible Christian chapel, North Third Street, Kensington · the Sunday after

He was back at his loom by the middle of the week. On Sunday, at the tea the congregation took together after meeting, Brother Royle asked where he had been.

In the Jerseys. With a hunter named Cox.

And have you got him to leave off killing?

Him and his seven sons and their seven wives. They are settled in it. I do not think they will be moved.

Has the man no wife of his own?

He has, said Abel. *She signed our paper in the Front Street room when she was twelve years old. I ruled the line for her.*

It went around the table then who she was, and that she was not drowned. Some of the older women wept. After that the other thing began to go around. A young man put it into words.

Then she kept her pledge and ran his bullets. For twenty-eight years. She handed him the gun every morning and salted down what he brought home, and sat on the wagon and sold it. Can one of ours do that?

Not one of ours ever took a life, Abel said, *and she did not. Her husband put out his hand and she put into it what he asked for. I asked her. In all that time she never once wished a deer dead. The wish was his.*

He held up his own hand, which was calloused across the fingers from the shuttle.

A man with a whole skin may carry ratsbane home from the druggist in his bare palm, and wash, and eat his bread. It is the cut that lets it in. Find me the cut in her.

Like many of the Lancashire weavers he had most of Milton by heart from saying it over at the loom, and he said three lines of it.

Evil into the mind of God or Man
May come and go, so unapprov'd, and leave
No spot or blame behind

— Milton, Paradise Lost V.117–119

The young man said nothing more, and somebody poured the tea.

VI. The Meeting House

Kensington, and the Jersey Market · that winter

Another Sunday they asked him how it could be that fifteen rough people in the pines, who had never opened a book, were so ready. He told them what Susanna had shown him on the walk out to the stage road.

There was a board meeting house at a fork of two sand roads, he said. It had no preacher and had not had one in years. Its roof was sound, though, and its floor was swept, and the graves beside it were kept clear of brush. When it was built, in the grandfather's time, there had been a question of whose name should go first on the paper as the chief man of the work. The ironmaster who owned the furnace, a Philadelphia man, put down ten dollars. Old Hahn, who burned charcoal, put down twenty. They went up against each other by tens until the ironmaster said eighty. Hahn had ninety dollars in the world. He could see that if he said ninety the ironmaster would say a hundred and never feel it.

So he said, I will give the ninety, and I will give myself, and my wife, and my seven sons and their wives, to keep this house as long as we live. The neighbors said a man can always get money, but this one has given his own back. They put his name first. Afterward they told him he was free of it, and he would not be freed. The Coxes have swept that house ever since, every Saturday, and nobody has asked them to.

He said he thought that people who had kept one house so long would know another when they came to it.

. . .

The Cox wagon came over on the ferry that December the same as always. The market men looked into it for deer and found barrels. The family had raked the wild cranberry bogs in the last week before the hard frost, the sixteen of them working in a line, and there were cedar shingles stacked behind the barrels and a few sacks of charcoal.

Susanna sat forward on the wagon tongue in the Jersey Market, across the street from a house with its top windows shuttered, and measured out berries by the quart. She did not use a scoop. By noon her hands were red to the wrist, and when she rinsed them at the pump they came up clean, with no mark on them anywhere.

Background

The verse

> *He who has no wound on his hand, may touch poison with his hand; poison does not affect one who has no wound; nor is there evil for one who does not commit evil.*
>
> Dhammapada 124, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich man's daughter of Rājagaha, already a stream-enterer as a girl, looks down from the top floor of her father's house and sees the deer hunter Kukkuṭamitta drive his cart of venison into the city. She slips out in soiled clothes with a waterpot, follows his cart and marries him, and her parents hold her funeral. She bears him seven sons. One dawn the Buddha walks to the hunter's empty nets, leaves a footprint and sits under a bush. The hunter draws his bow and is fixed there, unable to shoot or lower it; so are his seven sons; the wife arrives and cries, "Do not kill my father," and their hearts soften. All fifteen give up killing. The monks then ask how a stream-enterer could have handed her husband his bow and arrows for so many years, and the Buddha answers with the verse of the unwounded hand. A story of the past explains their readiness: a country rich man, outbid by a city rich man for the honor of leading the building of a shrine, gave himself, his wife, his seven sons and their wives to serve it. Read the full commentary story.

Philadelphia and the New Jersey Pine Barrens

Philadelphia and the Pines, 1821–1849

The Bible Christian Church began in Salford, Lancashire, where members signed a pledge to eat no meat and drink no alcohol. In 1817 the Rev. William Metcalfe brought a party of them to Philadelphia. Their church in Kensington was the first vegetarian congregation in the United States, a generation before Sylvester Graham, and Metcalfe helped found the American Vegetarian Society in 1850. He appears here only by name; The congregation first met in the schoolroom Metcalfe rented behind No. 10 North Front Street and from 1823 had its own chapel on North Third Street above Girard Avenue, as the church's centennial history records. Abel Horrocks, Hannah Schofield and Brother Royle are invented, as are the Ashmeads and the Coxes.

Market sheds ran down the middle of High Street, now Market Street, until 1859. The shed between Front and Second, nearest the ferry, was the Jersey Market, where New Jersey people sold what they brought across the river; an ordinance of 1822 had it rebuilt. Game, venison included, was sold in the city's markets through the century. The Pine Barrens of southern New Jersey supported bog-iron furnaces, charcoal burning, cedar cutting and, from the 1830s, cranberry growing. Local tradition has long held that some Piney families descend from Hessian soldiers who deserted during the Revolution. A "levy" was the Philadelphia name for the Spanish real, worth twelve and a half cents.

After the story of the hunter Kukkuṭamitta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 124). The original. Verse from John Milton, *Paradise Lost* (1667). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.9

The Mantle

> *His trouble shall return on his own head, and his unrighteousness shall come down on his own crown.*
> *— Psalm 7:17 (Septuagint)*

Tak ya slyshal, at Pavlovsk Harbor.

I. The Road

Pavlovsk Harbor, Kodiak Island · October 1796

Stepan Volkov went out after bear on the morning after the feast of the Protection, with four dogs and a spear and a musket he did not mean to fire.

The dogs had come with him from Kamchatka. They were grey and yellow, with thick ruffs and tails that curled up over their backs, and he had fed them on seal meat and nothing else for a year so that the smell of meat would mean one thing to them. Their names were Volchok and Seryi and Buyan, and the bitch was Zhuchka, and she was the worst of them. The spear was a rogatina, the short heavy bear spear of the Siberian forests, with an iron crossbar under the blade so that a bear could not run up the shaft and take the man holding it. The musket was the company's. Powder at the harbor was handed out by the measure and written against a man's share, and a man who burned powder and came back without meat owed for the powder. Volkov already owed for a great deal.

He had come out from Okhotsk six years before on a half share, and the half share had become a debt, the way it did for nearly everyone. He had been on the sea otter hunts, when the company sent the island men out in their skin boats by the hundred, two to a boat, down the coast to places where some of them drowned and some of them were killed and

the rest came home thinner. He had kept order on those hunts. He had kept order in the villages too, and in the sod houses, and some of what he had done there the monks had written down in a letter, and the letter had gone to Irkutsk and perhaps to Petersburg. That was the trouble with monks. They wrote things down.

There had been ten of them when the ship came in two autumns before, out of the far north of Russia, from an island monastery in a lake. They had been promised a church and a house and flour, and they found none of it, and they had dug their own gardens with wooden spades and raised a church out of raw spruce, and they went out into the villages and baptized whole families at a time, and taught the children their letters, and stood between the company men and the island people when they could, and wrote down what they saw when they could not. One of them had gone over to the mainland the year before and not come back. Nobody at the harbor knew what had happened to him, though everybody had a story.

Volkov took the path north out of the settlement, past the church, which still smelled of pitch, and up into the trees. The fog was in the spruce. Water dripped off every needle. The dogs ran ahead with their noses down and came back and ran ahead again.

At the place where the path forked, one branch going on to the bear country and one going down to the village on the bay, he met the young monk.

He was the one called Savvaty, a tall boy from somewhere on the Onega with a beard that would not fill in. He wore the black cassock and over it the long black mantle the monks wore, fastened at the throat with a hook, falling to his heels, always wet at the hem on this island. He had a board under his arm with the alphabet painted on it, and on his feet a pair of sealskin boots that one of the island women had sewn him, because his Russian boots had rotted through in the first winter.

God help you, Stepan Ivanovich, said the monk, the way you greet a man going to work.

Volkov did not answer. Where he came from, in the White Russian country near Mogilev, long before the regiment and the prison and

Irkutsk and the ship, everybody knew that a man who met a priest on the road to his work had better turn around and go home and take a holiday, because nothing good would come to him that day. A monk was worse than a priest. A monk was all black.

He could not go home. He owed for the powder already. So he did the other thing. He spat three times over his left shoulder, and the wind, which was coming off the sea from the left, brought it all back into his beard. Then he stood aside at the edge of the path and waited, with the dogs whining around his knees, until the black mantle had gone down the slope through the trees toward the bay and out of sight. Then he walked back the way he had come for forty paces, crossing the path from one side to the other and back, so that whatever was watching would be confused and think he had never met anybody. Then he turned and went on.

II. The Letters

The village on the bay

THE VILLAGE WAS ELEVEN HOUSES DUG INTO THE SLOPE ABOVE the beach, with grass growing on the roofs and smoke coming out of holes in the grass, so that from the trail it looked like the hillside was smoldering. There were racks of split salmon drying along the beach, red as cut cedar, and skin boats turned over on the stones. There were very few men. The company had taken the men in the spring for the otter hunt, and they had not come back yet, and some of them would not.

The children saw Savvaty coming and ran down to the waterline, where the tide had left the sand smooth and hard. He drew the letters for them with a stick, big as a man's arm, and they shouted the names after him the way he had shouted them in the parish school on the Onega when he was six. *Az. Buki. Vedi. Glagol. Dobro.* A girl named Matrena could do the whole line by herself and would do it whether anybody asked her or not. Then the tide came in over the letters, as it did every day, and took them, and the next day he drew them again.

Akulina fed him. She was a widow, or perhaps not; her husband had gone on the hunt the year before and not come back, and nobody had told her anything. Her son was eleven and was being kept at the harbor, in the company barracks, with the sons of other villages, so that their fathers would go out on the hunts and come back and bring the skins. The company called these boys hostages, in the plain way that the company said things. Akulina had sewn the sealskin boots on Savvaty's feet. She had sewn them in four days, with sinew, so tight that they did not let in water, and she had looked at his face when he put them on and laughed for the first time since he had known her.

She gave him dried salmon and a wooden bowl of seal oil to dip it in, and a handful of the last blue berries of the year, and he ate sitting on the floor of her house in the smoke with his mantle folded under him. Afterward he went with her to sit beside an old man who was dying of a cough, and held the old man's hand, and said the prayers he knew. He did not know very many. He was not a priest. He had been a monk for three years and a novice for four before that, and before that a fisherman's son, and he still did not know what to say to the dying except the prayers and his own name.

Akulina told him, while the old man slept, that Stepan Volkov had come to the village again in the summer while the men were gone. She told him which house. She did not tell him more than that and he did not ask. He had written it down the last time, and Father Paisy had put it in a letter, and the letter had gone on a ship, and Volkov had come again anyway.

Savvaty said he would tell Father Paisy. Akulina looked at him the way she had when she laughed at the boots, only without laughing.

He left in the late afternoon to be back at the harbor before dark. The children walked him up as far as the trees, shouting the letters after him, and then went back down.

III. The Spruce

The north trail · evening

VOLKOV'S DOGS FOUND BEAR SIGN BEFORE NOON ALONG A SALmon creek, where the fish were dying in the shallows with their skins gone white, and the banks were trampled and littered with heads. They found the bed where a bear had lain up in the alders, pressed flat and still smelling of him. They found where he had gone up the mountain. It began to rain. The dogs ran the track up into the rocks above the trees and lost it on the bare stone in the rain and ran back and forth on the slope crying. Zhuchka cut her foot on something and came back holding it up. By the middle of the afternoon the cloud was down on the mountain so thick Volkov could not see the dogs, only hear them.

He had not fired. That was something. He walked back down through the alders soaked to the waist and through the spruce in the half dark with nothing on his shoulders and the dogs strung out behind him with their tails down.

At the fork, coming up the path from the bay, there was the black mantle again.

Volkov stopped. He had done everything right that morning. He had spat and stood aside and walked back across the road, and none of it had worked, and here the thing was, in front of his face a second time, the way bad luck comes back around to sit on a man when he has done his best to shake it off.

You, he said. *Black crow.*

Savvaty stopped too. He was tired, and his mind was still in the smoke of Akulina's house with the old man's hand, and it took him a moment to understand who was standing in the path, and then he understood everything at once, from the man's face and the way the dogs had gone quiet.

This morning I met you, said Volkov. *And I've walked all day in the rain for nothing. And now you're in front of my face again. I'm going to let the dogs have you, and that's all I have to say about it.*

Stepan Ivanovich, said the monk. *Don't do this. I beg you.*

Volkov said one word to the dogs, the word for take, and they went.

Savvaty had grown up climbing. There had been no trees on the Onega shore the size of these, but there had been masts. The spruce at the side of the path had dead branches all the way down its trunk, the way spruce do in the dark of a forest, and he went up them with the mantle tangling at his legs and the pitch sticking his hands and the dogs' teeth snapping at his heels, and he came to a fork in the trunk about a man's height above the ground and wedged himself into it and pulled his feet up. The dogs leapt at the trunk and fell back and leapt again. Their claws tore the bark. Their noise went up into the dripping branches and came down again on all sides, as if there were twenty of them.

Volkov came up to the tree, taking his time.

Don't think you've gotten away from me, he said, *just because you climbed a tree.*

He reached up with the rogatina and put the point of it into the sole of the monk's foot, through the sealskin.

Savvaty cried out. *Don't. Please. Don't do this.*

Volkov did not answer. He drew back the spear and put it in again. And again. The blade was made for bears, wide and short and sharp on both edges, and it went through the sole Akulina had sewn as if the sole were cloth. When the one foot was pierced through and through, so that blood ran out of the boot and down the trunk and the dogs went mad at the smell of it, Savvaty drew that foot up under him and let the other one hang, because there was nowhere to put it in the fork of the tree. Volkov began on that one.

Savvaty tried to pray. At the monastery in the lake they read the whole Psalter through every week, and he had read it every week for seven years, and the psalm that came to him in the tree was the seventh, because it was the one he had read that morning before dawn by the lamp in his cell.

> *O Lord my God, in thee have I trusted: save me from all them that persecute me, and deliver me. Lest at any time the enemy seize my soul as a lion, while there is none to ransom, nor to save.*
>
> *— Psalm 7:2–3 (Septuagint)*

He got further than that. He got as far as the verse that says *judge me, O Lord, according to my righteousness, and according to my innocence that is in me,* and then the words went. When the second foot was pierced through, he drew it up beside the first, and it was as if somebody were holding burning splinters to the soles of both his feet, the way they light a cottage at home in the winter, one splinter after another, and he could not hold his mind on anything at all. He shut his eyes. He held on to the tree. Somewhere in that, the hook at his throat came undone.

He did not feel the mantle go. It slid from his shoulders all at once, heavy with the day's rain, the whole long black length of it, and it fell straight down out of the tree onto the man who was standing underneath with his face turned up, and covered him from the crown of his head to the ground.

IV. The Stick

The same place · after dark

The dogs had been told to take the black robe, and the black robe had come down out of the tree. They did what they had been fed a year on seal meat to do.

Volkov's voice came out of the cloth once, muffled, and then again, and the dogs did not know it in there under the smell of the monk and the wet wool and the blood that was already running down the trunk. Or they knew it too late. Savvaty did not open his eyes. He would hear it the rest of his life, on certain nights, in a certain wind. It went on for longer than it should have. Then it stopped, and for a while there was only the sound of the dogs, and then not even that.

When he opened his eyes it was nearly dark. The dogs had come out from under the folds of the mantle and were standing in a ring around

the tree in the dripping half light, looking up, panting, waiting for the rest of what they had been told to take.

He broke a dead branch off the trunk beside him and threw it down among them.

They looked up at the sound and saw him: the monk, in the tree, in his cassock, whole. Zhuchka saw him first. She put her ears back flat against her skull. Then the others saw him, and all four of them stood very still and looked at him, and then at what was on the ground, and then at him again. Their tails went down. Then, one after another, without a sound, they turned and went away into the spruce, up the hill, away from the harbor and away from the village, and did not come back.

Savvaty stayed in the tree a long time. Then he climbed down, which was harder than climbing up, because he could not put weight on his feet and had to let himself down by his arms from branch to branch. At the bottom he sat in the wet needles and did not look at the mantle. Then he did look at it. It was lying where it had fallen, and there was something under it. He did not lift it. He thought, very clearly, that it was his mantle, that it had been put on him with his vows, that the abbot on the island in the lake had laid it over his shoulders and called him by his new name, and that it was the mantle that had done this. He left it where it lay, over what it covered, and crossed himself, and began to go home.

It was two miles. He did most of it on his knees. Toward the end he walked again, because he wanted to come in standing up, and the boots Akulina had sewn so tight that they would not let water in did not let the blood out either, and they squelched at every step.

V. The Basin

The monks' house · that night

Father Paisy was seventy-one years old and had been at the monastery in the lake for forty of them. He had been a carpenter there and he was a gardener here, because somebody had to make potatoes grow in this ground and nobody else could. He had a long grey beard that he tucked into his belt when he dug, and very large hands, and he

DID NOT SPEAK MUCH, SO THAT PEOPLE AT THE HARBOR WHO had known him two years could not have told you what his voice sounded like.

He was sitting up by the stove reading when Savvaty came in. He looked at the boy's face, and at the boots, and at the boy's shoulders with no mantle on them, and he did not ask anything. He put down the book and got up and heated water in the kettle and poured it into a basin with a handful of sea salt, and knelt on the floor and cut the boots off with his knife, a long careful cut down each side, because they could not be pulled off. Then he put the boy's feet in the basin.

The water turned dark. Savvaty told him all of it, beginning at the beginning, at the fork in the path in the morning, the spitting and the standing aside and the walking back. The letters on the beach. The old man in the smoke. The dogs. The spear. The psalm. The hook at his throat, which he had not felt. What he had heard and not seen. The stick. The mantle, lying over what it covered, which he had left there.

It was my mantle, he said. *Father, it was because of my mantle that he died. I should have held on to it. I should have kept my mind. I don't know any more what I am. Am I still clean, Father? Am I still a monk?*

Father Paisy lifted one foot out of the water and looked at the sole of it, where there were five holes, and put it back.

You are clean, he said. *You are a monk. The one who went after somebody who had done him no harm is the one who is gone.*

He was quiet for a while, washing. Then he said, *And it is not the first time for that one.*

You knew him? Before?

I knew him at home.

And while he washed the boy's feet, Father Paisy told him a story, which was the most anybody at the harbor ever heard him say at one time.

On the shore of the lake across from the monastery, he said, when he was a young monk, there was a bonesetter who went from village to village setting arms and pulling teeth. One spring nobody in that village had broken anything, and nobody in the next village either, and he was

going hungry. Going out through the village gate he saw a crowd of little boys playing under the old willow beside the gate, and in a hole in the willow trunk he saw an adder lying with its head out in the sun. And the bonesetter thought, If one of these boys is bitten, they will need me, and I will eat. So he said to them, Boys, there is a young starling in that hole. Reach in and catch it. And the biggest boy reached in and took the snake by the neck and pulled it out, and when he felt in his hand what it was, he screamed and threw it as hard as he could, away from himself. It landed on the bonesetter, who was standing right there to watch. It went around his neck and bit him in the throat, and he died under the willow by the gate before anyone could fetch the priest.

Savvaty looked at him. *That was forty years ago. That was the same man?*

It is always the same man, said Father Paisy.

He took the boy's feet out of the basin and dried them with a towel, one at a time, and wrapped them in clean linen, and sat back on his heels. Then he finished the psalm that Savvaty had not been able to finish in the tree, saying it the way you say a thing you have said every week for fifty years, without any weight on it at all.

> *He has opened a pit, and dug it up, and he shall fall into the ditch which he has made. His trouble shall return on his own head, and his unrighteousness shall come down on his own crown.*
>
> *— Psalm 7:16–17 (Septuagint)*

Then he went out into the yard with the basin and threw the water out on the ground, downwind, the way you throw anything out on that island if you do not want it back in your face.

VI. The Wind

Pavlovsk Harbor · winter into spring, 1797

Men went up the north trail in the morning with lanterns they did not need, and came back with the mantle folded over a pole between two of them, and under it what there was of Stepan Volkov,

WHICH WAS NOT ENOUGH TO NEED A COFFIN OF ANY SIZE. They buried it at the edge of the graveyard behind the church. Father Paisy read the service. Savvaty stood beside him on two crutches the carpenter at the harbor had made, and held the censer, and kept it swinging.

The company men stood with their caps in their hands and did not look at the monks. Afterward some of them said in the barracks that the black-robes had set the dogs on him, that everybody knew they could do things like that, that they had been writing letters against him for a year and now they had found another way. The clerk wrote in the harbor book that the promyshlennik Volkov had been killed in the forest by his own dogs, which had run off, and that the matter had been reported to the manager. The manager did not come to the burial. Nobody had expected him to. What Volkov had owed for powder was written off, along with the rest of what he owed, and his musket went back to the store.

The dogs were seen all that winter on the ridges above the bay, four of them, and then three, gone thin and wild. They never came near a man again. Once Matrena saw them at the edge of the trees when she was gathering wood, and they looked at her, and went away.

Father Paisy had gone up the trail himself on the second day and found the place, and brought back the hook from the mantle's throat, which had been torn off, and sewn it on again. He washed the mantle in the creek behind the house in water so cold it made his hands ache, because cold water takes blood out and hot water sets it, and he hung it on a peg beside the stove, and there it stayed. Savvaty would not touch it. All winter he wore an old coat of Father Paisy's over his cassock and sat by the stove with his feet wrapped up and read the Psalter through, once a week, every week, and when he came to the seventh psalm he read it through to the end.

His feet healed by Lent. The scars were white and puckered on both soles, five on one foot and four on the other, and they would be there when he was buried on that island fifty years later. Akulina made him new boots without his asking. She made them a size larger so the scars would not be pressed, and she did not laugh this time when he put them

on, but she held on to his arm for a moment, very hard, as though he had been away somewhere.

On the first fine morning after Easter, Father Paisy took the mantle down from its peg and held it out to him.

Savvaty took it. He carried it up behind the church to the headland where the wind came straight off the sea, the way it nearly always does there, and turned his back to the wind and shook the mantle out in front of him, hard, three times. All winter's dust from beside the stove went out of it, and a few old spruce needles, and the dry grit of the island, and blew away in a long grey breath over the edge of the cliff and out over the harbor toward the mountains, and none of it came back.

He put it on. He fastened the hook at his throat. Then he went down the hill and took the north trail, toward the bay, where the tide would be out and the sand would be smooth and hard, and the children would be waiting for the letters.

Background

The verse

> *If a man offend a harmless, pure, and innocent person, the evil falls back upon that fool, like light dust thrown up against the wind.*
>
> Dhammapada 125, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the hunter Koka meets a monk on his alms round in the morning and blames him when he catches nothing all day. Meeting him again in the evening, he sets his dogs on him. The monk climbs a tree, and Koka pierces the soles of his feet with an arrow point until, in his agony, the monk's robe slips off and falls over the hunter. The dogs, thinking the monk has fallen, tear their own master apart, then run off into the forest when the monk throws a stick and they see him. The monk asks the Buddha whether he is to blame and whether he is still a monk. The Buddha tells him he is innocent, and adds a story from a past life in which the same man, as a hungry physician, told boys a snake was a mynah bird and was killed when they threw it back at him. Read the full commentary story, or about the Dhammapada.

Kodiak Island, Russian America

Kodiak, 1796

Russian fur traders, the promyshlenniki, took hold of Kodiak Island in 1784, when Grigory Shelikhov's men killed hundreds of Sugpiaq people at the Awa'uq massacre. In 1792 the company's manager, Alexander Baranov, moved its post to St. Paul's Harbor, Pavlovskaya Gavan, the beginning of today's Kodiak. The company took hostages from Alutiiq villages and sent the men out in fleets of skin kayaks to hunt sea otter. The population of the region fell sharply in these years from hunting losses, hardship and disease.

On September 24, 1794, ten monks and novices from the Valaam Monastery on Lake Ladoga reached Kodiak. Their supplies never came as promised, and they tilled their gardens with wooden tools. They reported the company's abuses to Russia, which set them against Baranov. One of them, Juvenaly, was killed on the mainland in 1796. Another, Herman, stayed on the islands until his death in 1837 and is honored as a saint. The superstition Volkov follows comes from accounts of peasant belief in White Russia: meeting a priest on the way to work was unlucky, and a man who had to go on would wait for the priest to pass, then walk back some distance so the spirits would think he had never met him, as a 1916 newspaper account describes it.

After the story of the hunter Koka's dogs from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 125). The original. Scripture from Sir Lancelot Brenton's translation of the Septuagint (1844). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

9.10

The Cleaning Table

> *The rewards or punishments appointed for men's souls after the Particular Judgment are Heaven, Purgatory, and Hell.*
> *— Baltimore Catechism No. 1, Q. 412*

The way I heard it, on Southwest Forty-Seventh Terrace.

I. Twelve Years

Cape Coral, Florida · 1999–2011

Father Leo Brandl came down to Cape Coral in 1999, when the Diocese of St. Cloud retired him, because his lungs could not take another January in Stearns County. He was seventy. He had been a priest forty-three years, in six parishes with steeples you could see from the next town and a hundred Schmitts and Theisens apiece. He arrived in Florida with two suitcases, a set of golf clubs he did not use, and the name of one family he knew.

Roger and Mary Jo Kessler had come down from St. Cloud three years before. Roger had a jewelry store in a strip mall on Del Prado Boulevard, between a Subway and a place that did nails, and they had a ranch house with a pool cage on a canal off the Caloosahatchee, one of the four hundred miles of canals the developers had dug out of the mangroves in the fifties to sell lots to people from Ohio. Mary Jo had been in Father Leo's eighth-grade religion class in Albany in 1967. The first night he was in town she had him to supper, and he came the next night too, and after that, for twelve years, he ate his supper at their table every night of the week except Sundays, when he said the nine o'clock at the parish and ate with the pastor.

He had his chair. He had his napkin ring, a wooden one Kyle made in shop class. Mary Jo kept his pills in a cup on the windowsill and his decaf in its own can. He said grace, a short one, the one from home, and ate whatever she put down, and told the same stories about Albany and Richmond and Melrose until the Kessler kids could tell them back to him. Kyle, the youngest, grew up at that table and went to work behind the counter at the store, and Roger taught him the bench. Nobody in that house in twelve years ever heard Father Leo say a sharp word about a living person.

In March he and Roger went to spring training. They had gone every year since 1999, out Daniels Parkway to Hammond Stadium to sit in the sun behind the Twins dugout with men from Edina and Fargo and Sioux Falls in the same windbreakers, and watch the regulars play three innings and the kids from the minor-league camps play the rest. Father Leo kept score in pencil. On the evenings after, the two of them sat out on the dock while Roger cleaned whatever he had caught that day, with the radio on the cleaning table giving them the end of whatever game there was.

And every evening, at the hour when Roger cleaned fish, the heron came.

He was a great blue, four feet tall, gray as a filing cabinet, with a black plume going back from his eye. He had come first in 2003, standing at the end of the dock in the evening like somebody waiting to be served, and Roger had thrown him a sheepshead head, and that was that. Kyle named him Herb, after Herb Carneal, who had done the Twins on the radio since before Kyle was born, because he showed up every night at seven. Herb would walk right up the dock to the cleaning table, one long careful step and then another, and stand there an arm's length from Roger with his neck pulled down into his shoulders, and wait, and Roger would toss him the heads and the frames and the guts, and he would take them out of the air. He went up and down the canal all day, to the other docks, but at seven he came to the Kesslers'. Father Leo said Herb was the only parishioner he had ever had who was never once late.

II. The Pearl

Friday, March 25, 2011

It was the third Friday in Lent. Roger had been out at the mouth of the river since noon and come home with six sheepshead, and Mary Jo wanted them for supper before Stations, so he was at the cleaning table at a quarter to six with his hands red to the wrists. Father Leo was in his lawn chair. Herb was at the end of the dock. The radio on the table had the scores from the afternoon; the Twins had lost again, the way they were going to lose all that year.

A boat came down the canal, slow, a white center-console with two big outboards, and swung in to the dock. It was Gary Lund's son-in-law. Gary Lund owned four car dealerships on Pine Island Road and was on television every night of the week in a gold paper crown, as the Car King of Cape Coral, and he was the biggest customer the store had, and the only one Roger had ever been afraid of. The son-in-law did not get off the boat. He held out a little blue velvet bag.

Gary says clean it, drill it, put it on a chain. He wants it Sunday for Cheryl. It's their fortieth.

Roger knew what it was before he had it open. It was the pearl from Gary's grandmother, which he had been allowed to see once, in the store, and had not been allowed to touch. It was a natural pearl, not a cultured one, fished up somewhere in the Persian Gulf before the First World War, the size of a chickpea, white with a rose light in it, and Roger had looked it up afterward and knew that it was worth more than the house behind him.

He had blood on his hands. He tipped it out of the bag anyway, onto his palm, because he could not help it, and looked at it, and set it down on a square of clean paper towel on the corner of the table, away from the fish. The boat backed off and went on down the canal. Roger went up to the house to wash his hands and get his loupe.

Herb had watched the whole thing from the end of the dock. As soon as Roger was gone he came up the boards, one long step and then another, to the corner of the table, and put his head down and looked at the

pearl a moment with one yellow eye. It had blood on it, and fish slime, and it smelled like the table, and it was about the size of the things that came off the table to him every night. He took it, and tipped his bill up, and it went down his long neck in a lump.

Father Leo saw it. He was ten feet away in his lawn chair with his hands on his knees.

Roger came back down with clean hands and the loupe in his pocket, and the paper towel was there, and the pearl was not.

He looked under the table. He looked in the fish bucket and in the gut bucket and between the boards of the dock with a flashlight. He went up to the house, where Mary Jo was cutting potatoes and Kyle was eating a slice of cheese, and asked them, and they said no, Dad, no, honey, what pearl. He came back down and looked in the water, which was black. He looked at Father Leo.

Then he went up again and got Mary Jo by the elbow and took her out on the lanai and said it in a whisper. *He took it. Leo took it. There was nobody else on the dock.*

Roger Kessler. Don't you ever say that. Twelve years that man has sat at our table, and I have never once seen him so much as take the last roll.

Then where is it?

I don't know where it is. I know where it isn't.

He went back down. *Father. Did you pick up that pearl? Maybe you just wanted to look at it.*

No, Roger. I didn't take it.

There was nobody else here. It was you and me and it was on the table. Give it back and we'll forget it.

I don't have it.

Mary Jo came down the lawn with her car keys. They were late for Stations and Kyle was already in the car. She looked at her husband's face.

Roger, whatever you're thinking, stop thinking it. If we have to sell the store, we'll sell the store. I'd rather go back to St. Cloud and clean houses.

If we sold the store, said Roger, *and this house, and the boat, and Kyle's truck, we couldn't pay for that pearl.*

She stood there a moment longer. Then she went, because the car was running and she did not believe it of him either. She did not believe it of anybody she knew.

III. Stations

The dock · dusk

He asked again, and again. It got dark. The lights came on under the pool cages up and down the canal, and the dock light came on over the table on its timer, and the bugs began. Father Leo sat in the lawn chair and said no, Roger, I don't have it, and that was all he said.

Roger was a man who had never in his life hit anybody, not his kids, not a dog. He was sixty-one years old and on blood-pressure pills and sang bass in the choir. Afterward he could not have said how it began, only that he had been talking and then he had the dock line off the cleat in his hands, and he had tied the old man to the piling by the chest with it, the way you would tie a boat, and was standing over him with the fish club from the table, the short heavy billy he used to quiet the fish. And then he was not talking.

He hit him on the head. He hit him again. The blood came out of Father Leo's hair and ran down into his eyes, and then it came out of his ears, and out of his nose, and his eyes were open very wide and looked as if they were pushing out of his face, and he did not say anything at all. He went down sideways against the piling as far as the rope would let him, and lay with his cheek on the boards.

There was blood on the boards. Herb came up the dock, one long step and then another, out of the dark at the end into the light, with his neck down, the way he came up every night for the fish, and put the tip of his bill in the blood by the old man's face and began to drink.

Roger kicked him. He was not kicking the bird; he was kicking at everything. It was one kick with a boat shoe, and it caught Herb high on the long neck, and the bird went over on the boards and lay on his back with his yellow legs folded up and his wings half open, and did not move again.

Father Leo turned his head a little on the boards and looked at him.

Roger, he said. His voice was all right. *Loosen that rope a little. Go look at Herb. See if he's dead.*

You'll be dead like him.

Herb took it. He swallowed it off the paper while you were washing up. I watched him do it. He shut his eyes. *If he'd still been alive, I'd have let you go on till I was dead before I told you.*

Roger stood there with the club. Then he dropped it, and took the fillet knife off the table, and knelt by the bird and opened his throat down the long neck, the way he would have opened a fish, and the pearl was the first thing that came out into his hand, white, with the rose light in it, under the dock light, with Herb's blood on it.

He began to shake. He shook so that he dropped the knife and it went between the boards into the canal. He got the rope off the old man with his hands shaking and could not untie it and cut it finally on the scaler, and then he was on his knees on the boards with his face down on Father Leo's shoes.

Father. Forgive me. I didn't know. I didn't know what I was doing.

Father Leo had got himself sitting up against the piling. He put his hand on the back of Roger's head.

It's not your fault, Roger, he said. *And it's not mine. It's the way this world goes around. That's all. I forgive you. You know I do.*

Then come up to the house. Please. Mary Jo will be back. Come in and sit in your chair.

The old man looked at the house, at the lights in the kitchen and the table set for four under the lamp, his napkin in its wooden ring.

No, he said. *I've been going in under people's roofs since 1956. That's how this happened. I'm not going in under anybody's roof again. From now on, whatever anybody hands me, I'll take it at the door. I can still walk.*

He would not go to the hospital. He let Roger wet a dish towel in the cooler and hold it to his head, and then he took it and held it himself, and walked home, the two streets to his condo, slowly, in the dark, with the towel on his head and his other hand on the fences.

IV. At the Door

Southwest Forty-Seventh Terrace · the last week of March

MARY JO FOUND ROGER ON THE DOCK WHEN SHE CAME HOME from Stations, sitting next to the dead heron with the pearl in his open hand. She went straight down the street to Father Leo's and banged on the door until he opened it. He had washed. There was a cut in his scalp and a bruise coming up the side of his face like weather. He said he had bumped it. He said he was fine. He would not go to the hospital for her either.

The next evening at six he did not come to supper. He came down the street instead, slowly, and stood at the Kesslers' front door and rang, and when Mary Jo opened it he would not come in. She brought him a plate, and he ate a few bites of it standing on the step with the plate in his hand, and gave it back to her, and thanked her, and went on to the next house.

He did that every night that week. He went down Southwest Forty-Seventh Terrace in the evening the way the mailman went down it in the morning, and rang at the doors of people he had married and buried and heard the confessions of, Minnesotans and Michiganders and a family from Puerto Rico, and stood on their welcome mats and would not come in. They thought he was getting confused. They brought him whatever was on their stove: a piece of meatloaf, a spoonful of hotdish on a paper plate, half a sandwich, a cup of soup, rice and beans. He took a bite or two at each door, and said thank you, and went on. By the end of the street he had had his supper, a little from every house. He said he had never eaten better in his life. He said it was a good thing he could still walk.

On Thursday night he went to bed and did not get up. Mary Jo found him in the morning when he did not answer his phone. The medical examiner said it was bleeding inside the skull, slow, the kind that can let a man walk around and talk for days before it takes him, and that it came from blows to the head, and asked who had struck him. Roger told them.

He told the detective the whole thing at the kitchen table, from the boat to the knife, and signed it.

Kyle drilled the pearl. It was on its chain on Sunday, and Gary Lund's wife wore it at the Westin for their fortieth, and Gary never said a word to Roger about any of it, before or after.

V. Heaven, Purgatory, and Hell

Cape Coral · 2011–2019

Roger pleaded to manslaughter in the fall and went to the state prison up at Raiford. Mary Jo drove up to see him the first Saturday of every month, five hours each way. He wrote her every week in the beginning, and then less, and the letters were mostly about the food and the noise and a man from Ohio in the next bunk. In 2017 his heart stopped in the yard. He was sixty-seven. She buried him in St. Cloud next to his parents.

Kyle's girlfriend had a baby that December, a boy, and they named him Leo, and when Kyle's girlfriend went back to Fort Myers in 2013, the boy stayed with his grandmother on the canal. He was a tall, thin, silent child who ate raw shrimp out of the bait bucket when nobody was looking. From the time he could walk he went down to the end of the dock in the evenings and stood on one leg at the edge of the boards, watching the water, without moving, for as long as anyone would let him. The first time Mary Jo saw him do it she sat down on the lanai step and could not get up for a while.

Look at that, she said to Kyle. *Herb's back.* It was a family joke after that, and she was the only one who did not quite say it as a joke.

Mary Jo died in the spring of 2019, in the hospice in Fort Myers, of the cancer she had not told anybody about until it was too late to matter. Half the parish came to the funeral, and the women from the Altar Society did the lunch, and people stood up one after another and said that she had been the kindest person they knew, and that wherever she was now she had earned it.

That May Leo was in the second grade and in Mrs. Theisen's First Communion class on Wednesday nights in the parish hall. Arlene Theisen was eighty-one. She had taught religion in Melrose for fifty years before she retired to Florida and started over, and she still taught from her mother's little catechism, printed in 1912 and held together with Scotch tape, though the diocese had sent her new books with pictures. The children had been asked to bring a question.

Leo raised his hand. *Where did my grandma go? And where did my grandpa go? And where did Father Leo go, that I'm named after? And where did Herb go?*

Some of the children laughed at Herb. Mrs. Theisen did not. She knew who Herb was. Everybody in that parish over the age of thirty knew. She looked at the boy for a while, and then she opened the little blue book to near the end, where it fell open by itself, and read it to the class the way she had read it to fifty years of children in Melrose, question and answer, so that they could say it back.

Q. What are the rewards or punishments appointed for men's souls after the Particular Judgment?
A. The rewards or punishments appointed for men's souls after the Particular Judgment are Heaven, Purgatory, and Hell.

Q. What is Hell?
A. Hell is a state to which the wicked are condemned, and in which they are deprived of the sight of God for all eternity, and are in dreadful torments.

Q. What is Purgatory?
A. Purgatory is a state in which those suffer for a time who die guilty of venial sins, or without having satisfied for the punishment due to their sins.

Q. What is Heaven?
A. Heaven is the state of everlasting life in which we see God face to face, are made like unto Him in glory, and enjoy eternal happiness.

— Baltimore Catechism No. 1, Q. 412–414, 420

She closed the book. *That's three places,* she said. *Your grandpa did a terrible thing, and he told the truth about it, and he was sorry, and it's not for me to say where that puts a man. Your grandma, I'd say she went the short way. And some people, Leo, there is nothing in them left to burn off when they go, nothing at all, and they go straight in and see Him face to face. I'd say Father Leo was one of those.*

And Herb?

Mrs. Theisen took off her glasses and folded them.

The book doesn't say about herons, she said. *Your grandma had her own opinion about that, and I wouldn't go against her.* She put her glasses back on. *Now. Who knows what a sacrament is?*

• • •

Kyle sold the house that summer. The new people tore out the old dock and put in a boat lift and a composite deck with lights set into the edges, and the cleaning table went out to the curb on bulk-trash day with the brown stain still on the corner of it, soaked into the wood where it would never come out. Leo and his father lived in an apartment off Santa Barbara Boulevard after that, with no water near it. On Sundays, after the nine o'clock, Kyle drove him down to the public pier at the Yacht Club, where there are always fishermen cleaning their catch at the end of the day and always a heron or two standing by them, waiting, and the boy would walk out to the end and stand beside the herons, on one leg, with his hands in his pockets, and they did not move away from him.

Background

The verse

> *Some people are born again; evil-doers go to hell; righteous people go to heaven; those who are free from all worldly desires attain Nirvana.*
>
> Dhammapada 126, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Tissa has taken his meals for twelve years at the house of a jeweler, who with his wife has looked after him like a parent. One day, while the

jeweler is cutting meat with the elder sitting by, King Pasenadi sends a gem to be cleaned and pierced. The jeweler takes it with bloody hands, sets it down and goes in to wash, and the household's pet heron, smelling the blood, swallows it before the elder's eyes. The jeweler asks his wife and sons, then accuses the elder. His wife pleads that in all those years she has never seen a flaw in him, and that they would do better to become slaves; the jeweler answers that all of them sold as slaves would not pay for the stone. He binds the elder's head with a rope and beats him until blood runs from his head, ears and nose. The heron comes to drink the blood, and the jeweler kills it with a kick. Only then does the elder tell him to look in the bird, saying he would have died rather than speak while it lived. The jeweler finds the gem, falls at his feet and is forgiven ("it was neither your fault nor mine"), but the elder vows never again to go under anyone's roof and to take alms only at the door, says a short verse about food cooked "little by little, house by house," and soon dies of the beating. The heron is reborn in the jeweler's wife's womb, the jeweler in hell, his wife in heaven, and the elder passes into final Nibbāna. Read the full commentary story, or about King Pasenadi.

Cape Coral, Florida

Cape Coral, 2011

Cape Coral was begun in 1957 by two brothers from Baltimore, Leonard and Jack Rosen, whose Gulf American Land Corporation dredged the mangrove flats across the Caloosahatchee from Fort Myers into building lots; the city has more than 400 miles of canals. Since Hammond Stadium opened in Fort Myers in 1991, the Minnesota Twins have held spring training there, and every February and March brings Minnesotans south to watch. The 2011 Twins went from first place the year before to last in the American League Central, at 63 wins and 99 losses. The great blue heron, the largest heron in North America and up to four and a half feet tall, lives mostly on fish and is at home wherever there is fish-bearing water, however built up. The Kesslers, the Lunds, Father Leo and the street are invented.

The Baltimore Catechism, issued in 1885 after the Third Plenary Council of Baltimore, was the standard Catholic school text in the United States from then until the late 1960s, and generations of children learned its questions and answers by heart; the passage here is from No. 1, the edition for First Communion classes. In Lent, Catholics abstain from meat on Fridays, and the Stations of the Cross are prayed especially on Lenten Fridays. A subdural hematoma, bleeding between the brain and its covering after a blow, can take days to show itself, with headache and growing confusion, and is especially common in the elderly.

After the story of the Elder Tissa, who frequented a jeweler, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 126). The original. Catechism from the Baltimore Catechism No. 1 (1885). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

9.11

A Jar of Sand

Ésta es justicia de Dios,
quien tal hace, que tal pague.
— Tirso de Molina, El burlador de Sevilla, Act III

Así lo oí contar, under Telegraph Hill.

I. The Black Bird

A rancho on the road down to Stockton · August 1850

That summer three parties of Chileans set out, each without knowing of the others, to see ño Bartolo at San Francisco. The first was five men walking down out of the southern mines. That spring the Americans had put a tax of twenty dollars a month on every foreigner who dug, and these five had paid it once and could not pay it twice.

Two days above Stockton they came to a rancho where a Sonoran woman fed travelers under a ramada thatched with tule. She would not take their money. She sat them in the shade and gave them beans and tortillas, and while the meat was frying she asked for the news from the mines, and they gave her all they had.

The fat caught. The flame went up the post and into the tule faster than anyone could stand. It was the hour when the wind comes up the valley, and the wind took one whole bundle of the thatch off the roof, burning, and carried it out over the yard as high as a mast.

A black bird was crossing just then. They had no such bird at home. In two years none of them had found a better name for it than *cuervo*, out of the story of Noah. It was flying straight and low the way those birds do, going somewhere. It put its neck directly into the burning bundle. The

tule closed around it. For a moment it was still flying, and then it came down in the middle of the yard, all black, and smoking.

The five men stood up from the table. The woman was beating at the ramada with a wet sack, and they helped her. Afterward they went and looked at the bird.

The whole sky to fly in, said the oldest, a man named Olegario. *What did it do, to die like that?*

Who would know?

Ño Bartolo would know.

They had meant to ask him only whether to go home.

II. Dead Calm

The bark Carmen, eleven degrees north · June 1850

THE SECOND PARTY CAME BY SEA. THE BARK *CARMEN* WAS forty days out of Valparaíso with ninety passengers and a cargo of flour when the wind left her. For nineteen days she lay in the same water. The sails hung. The pitch came up soft between the deck planks, and the water in the casks went down to a hand's depth and was served out by the cup. Sharks lay in the shadow of the hull the whole time and did not trouble to move.

By the twelfth day the passengers were saying that somebody on board was unlucky. By the nineteenth they had a hat and ninety-odd dry beans in it, all white but one.

The captain was a man named Rozas, and he had his wife aboard. She was nineteen. He had married her in March and would not leave her behind. Her name was Mercedes, and she was the prettiest thing any of them had seen since the hills above the harbor went under the horizon. She put her hand in the hat with the rest, and her hand came out with the black bean.

Again, the passengers said, and nobody argued. They put the bean back and shook the hat. She drew it a second time. They shook it a third time, and held it higher, and she reached up and drew it again.

Then they went aft in a body and looked Captain Rozas in the face.

Well, patrón?

He was a long time answering.

It is not right that ninety should die for one, he said. *Put her over.*

When they laid hands on her she screamed. The captain shut his eyes at it. Then he opened them and spoke again.

Wait. There is no sense in her gold going down with her. Take the earrings off, and the chain, and the rings. Wrap her in a piece of sailcloth. And I will not watch her fight on top of the water. Tie something to her neck that will take her straight down.

There was sand in the hold for ballast. They filled one of the earthen jars the wine had come in, a botija, and stopped it, and made it fast around her neck with a length of line. They did what he said in the order he said it. She went under at once, and the sharks came out of the shadow of the hull.

The wind came three days later, as wind does.

Among the ninety were a baker from the Almendral named Tadeo Briones, and his brother, and a laundress called Rosa who had held the hat the third time. On the day the *Carmen* anchored in the cove among the rotting ships, these three did not go up to the mines with the others. They had begun asking themselves a question at night.

What had she done? Rosa said. *A girl like that. What could she have done?*

Somebody on the beach told them there was an old man under the hill who weighed gold for the Chileans and knew the reasons of things.

III. Seven Sleeping Places

A limestone gulch in Calaveras County · July 1850

THE THIRD PARTY WAS SEVEN MEN FROM THE VALLEY OF THE Choapa, above Illapel. They had come up as peons for a patrón who had since died of fever, and they had worked their way from camp to camp with one wooden batea among them. They also were going down to San Francisco to see ño Bartolo, who was from their country.

One evening they came to a camp of Sonorans in a gulch, and asked for a place to lie. The Sonorans kept a cave for people passing through. It

was dry, and there was a shelf at the back with room for exactly seven men to sleep side by side. The seven thanked them and went in and slept.

In the night a rock as big as a chapel came down the opposite slope. It rolled across the gulch and stopped in the mouth of the cave like a stopper in a jar.

The Sonorans found it at daylight. *We gave them that cave,* they said. *We will get them out.* They sent up and down the country, and men came from seven camps. There were Chileans and Sonorans and Frenchmen, and a Kanaka sailor with a ship's tackle, and a dozen of the same Americans who had gone round in May with the tax collector. They brought bars and mules and powder. They dug under it and it settled. They blasted it and it blackened. The seven inside pushed until their shoulders bled, and the hundred outside hauled, and the rock did not move the width of a finger.

That went on for seven days. There was a drip of water at the back of the cave, so the seven lived. They had nothing to eat. By the fifth day they had stopped talking, and lay on the shelf in the dark with their knees drawn up.

On the seventh day, at about noon, the rock rolled away. Nobody was touching it. The men outside were sitting down to eat. It turned over once, slowly, and went on down the gulch and lay still. The seven came out into the light on their hands and knees.

When they could stand, the one called Lindor said what they were all thinking.

That was meant for us. For what, I do not know.

They met the five from the mines on the Stockton road, and the three from the ship on the beach at San Francisco. All three parties went up under the hill together.

IV. The Scale

Chilecito, under Telegraph Hill · the end of August

THE CHILEANS LIVED IN TENTS AND BOARD SHANTIES AT THE foot of Telegraph Hill, and the Americans called the place Little Chile. Bartolo Araya had a tent there with a table in it. He was past seventy. He

HAD GONE DOWN THE SILVER MINES OF ATACAMA AS A BOY with a hide sack on his back, and afterward he had spent forty years alone in that desert as a cateador, looking for veins. Now he kept a scale. The storekeepers' scales in San Francisco were known to lie, so the Chileans brought their dust to him. He weighed it for nothing, wrote the weight on a paper, and put his mark under it.

He was weighing when they came in, fifteen people into a tent made for four. He finished. Then he heard the five, and the three, and the seven, in that order. He did not interrupt any of them. Rosa was the only one who wept.

He turned to the five first.

In Colchagua there was a man who had a young ox. It would not take the yoke. It went a little way and lay down. He beat it, and it got up and went a little way and lay down again. He was a whole day at it. At the end of the day he said, Very well, lie there as long as you like. He went and got wheat straw. He bound it around the ox from head to tail the way you bind a sheaf, and he put fire to it.

And the bird was that man? said Olegario.

My grandmother would say he has been that bird seven times. I only keep the scale. I am telling you what was put in one pan.

He turned to the three from the ship.

There was a young wife who did all the work of her house with her own hands. She had a dog. It sat and watched her grind and cook, and when she went for wood or water it went behind her. One day some boys saw the two of them on the road and called out, Here comes the hunter with her hound, tonight we eat meat. She was ashamed. She beat the dog with sticks and stones to drive it home. It ran off a little and came back, because it could not do otherwise. That afternoon she took a rope and an empty botija and went down to a pool. She filled the jar with sand. The dog came up to her wagging. It had not had a good word from her all day. She tied one end of the rope to the jar and the other around its neck, and she rolled the jar down the bank into the water.

Nobody spoke. Then Tadeo Briones, the baker, said slowly, *The cook had a yellow dog on the ship. It followed her about. She could not have it near her. She would go white, and call for somebody to tie it.*

Bartolo did not answer that. He looked at the seven.

You are from the Choapa. When you were boys you kept the goats, a week each, turn about.

The seven looked at one another. It was Lindor who said it.

The lizard.

Then they told it themselves, all seven, each taking it from the last. They had been coming home with the goats and had started a lizard as long as a man's forearm. It outran them and went into an old heap of stones. The heap had seven gaps in it. They said, We will get him tomorrow, and each boy took a fistful of thorn twigs and stopped one gap. The next day they took the goats up the other side of the valley, and they forgot. On the seventh day they came by the heap and remembered. They pulled out the twigs. The lizard came out so thin they could see the light through it. It was shaking, and it did not seem to care what they did. One of them said, Do not kill it, it has had nothing for seven days. They stroked its back with one finger and said, Go with God.

You let it go, said Bartolo. *So the rock let you go.*

The tent was quiet. The scale stood on the table between them with its pans hanging level.

Taita, said the baker. *If a man has done a thing like that, is there nowhere he can get clear of it? If he went far enough?*

You went to the middle of the sea, Bartolo said. *These went inside a mountain. That bird had the whole sky. There is a saying older than I am.*

> *No hay plazo que no llegue ni deuda que no se pague.*
>
> *— Refranes de la lengua castellana (Barcelona, 1815)*

No term fails to come due, and no debt goes unpaid. And he said the other one, the one the crier calls in the street when a man is led out to be punished: *Quien tal hace, que tal pague.* Who does it, pays the same.

And us? said Rosa. *I held the hat. And the captain, with her earrings in his pocket?*

It is one scale, said Bartolo. *It does not tell me the day.*

They went out one at a time. It is said of those fifteen that none of them afterward lifted a hand against anything living, and that the baker fed whoever came to his oven door.

The cook's yellow dog had come ashore from the *Carmen* with nobody, and had followed Rosa up from the beach. It was sitting by the tent pole. She stood and looked at it for some time. Then she broke her bread and held out the half of it, and when she went up the hill it went behind her.

Bartolo put the weights back in their box, the smallest last. The pans swung a little each time someone walked past the tent, and came back to level.

Background

The verse

> *Not in the sky, not in the midst of the sea, not if we enter into the clefts of the mountains, is there known a spot in the whole world where a man might be freed from an evil deed.*
>
> Dhammapada 127, tr. F. Max Müller (1881), as printed; the Project Gutenberg text drops this ending and runs the verse into 128

In the commentary, three parties of monks travel to see the Buddha. The first, eating in a village, sees a kitchen fire catch the thatch; a burning bundle of grass floats into the air and a crow flies into it and is burned. The second is aboard a ship that stops dead in mid-ocean. The passengers cast lots for the unlucky one, and three times the lot falls on the captain's young wife; the captain has her jewels removed and a jar of sand tied to her neck so that he need not watch her struggle, and she is thrown overboard. The third party, seven monks, is shut in a cave for seven days by a fallen rock that no one can move and that at last rolls away by itself. The Buddha explains each by an old deed: the crow was a farmer who burned a balky ox in straw; the woman had drowned her faithful dog with a pot of sand; the seven monks, as cowherd boys, had stopped up a lizard in an anthill for seven days and then let it go. Asked whether there is anywhere a person can escape a deed, he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.

San Francisco, California

Little Chile, 1850

News of California gold reached Valparaíso in 1848, and Chileans were among the first to arrive by sea. Many were experienced miners; they brought the wooden gold pan, the batea, and the ore-crushing "Chili mill." Chilean companies often worked claims with hired peons, which American miners resented. In San Francisco they settled at the foot of Telegraph Hill in a quarter called Chilecito, Little Chile, which a nativist gang, the Hounds, attacked in July 1849. In 1850 the new state passed the Foreign Miners' Tax of twenty dollars a month, and many Chileans and Mexicans left the diggings. The limestone country of Calaveras County, where Chili Gulch keeps the Chileans' name, is full of caves; one near Cave City was already being shown to visitors in 1850. The *Carmen*, her captain, the rancho and everyone in the story are invented.

There are no crows or ravens native to South America, so the bird was new to these men. The proverb ño Bartolo quotes is given as it stands in the anonymous *Refranes de la lengua castellana* printed at Barcelona in 1815. The second saying, the old formula of the public crier, closes Tirso de Molina's *El burlador de Sevilla* (about 1630), where the stone guest speaks it twice. Both are quoted in the original Spanish; the English beside them is this story's own.

After the story of the three groups from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 127). The original. Sayings from *Refranes de la lengua castellana* (1815) and Tirso de Molina, *El burlador de Sevilla*, in Spanish. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

9.12

The Seventh Floor

> *Though they dig into the nether-world, thence shall My hand take them; and though they climb up to heaven, thence will I bring them down.*
> — *Amos 9:2*

Näin olen kuullut, in Finntown.

I. The Watch

Butte, Montana · 1917

Ferdinand Kahn had come to Butte in 1881 with a peddler's pack and a pair of boots that let in water, and by 1917 he owned one of the tallest buildings in Butte. The Kahn Block stood seven stories high on West Park Street, red brick and terra cotta, with his name cut into the stone over the door and a light court in the middle that went straight up through every floor to a roof of glass, so that on a clear day a woman buying gloves on the main floor could look up through six galleries of iron railing and see the sky. Kahn's sold silk from Lyon and pianos from Chicago and men's suits that came up from the basement tailors in two days. Kahn himself kept his office on the seventh floor, and from his window he could look across the whole of the Hill, the gallows frames and the smokestacks and the ore dumps and the shacks, and he liked to say that he could see every dollar in Butte from there, and that most of them were on their way to him.

He had a son, Julius, and a daughter, Sophie. In 1912 Sophie married a young doctor from Chicago named Nathan Brill, whose father had been a tinsmith in Kovno and whose mother still could not write her name. Kahn had not liked it. He had given them a house on West Granite Street

anyway, and an office for Nathan on the fifth floor of the Kahn Block with his name in gold leaf on the frosted glass, and in two years Nathan had the best practice uptown. He set the bones of mine superintendents and delivered the babies of their wives. In 1914 he delivered his own son, Benjamin, in the house on Granite Street, because he would not trust anybody else to do it.

On the eighth of June, 1917, the Granite Mountain shaft caught fire more than two thousand feet underground, and the smoke and the gas went out through the tunnels into the Speculator and the mines beyond it, and Dr. Brill went up the hill with every other doctor in Butte and stood at the collar of the shaft for three days.

He saw the old men first, the ones who had been mining forty years and knew enough to wall themselves into a drift with their own coats and wait. Some of them came up alive. He saw the young ones who had run. He saw the men who were dying already before the fire, with the miners' consumption in them from the rock dust, who came up coughing black and would have been dead in two years anyway, and who knew it, and who thanked him. Then the cages started bringing up the others. He saw them laid out on the ground in rows, more every day. He knew some of their faces from the street.

He went back to the office on the fifth floor in July and sat at the desk and could not do it. The superintendents' bones. Their wives' nerves. The gold leaf on the glass. In October, on a Thursday night, he took off his gold watch and set it on the dresser beside the bed where his wife and son were sleeping, and stood a while and looked at them, and picked up his bag and walked down the hill in the dark to the Cabbage Patch, east of Wyoming Street, where two hundred shacks leaned together between Mercury and Silver with an open sewer running down the middle and three miners to a bed, turn and turn about, one for each shift.

He took a shack on Mercury Street with a stove and a table and a cot, and put a card in the window that said DOCTOR in English and in Finnish and in Serbian, which a Finn named Matti Lahti wrote out for him. He did not charge. He ate wherever he was asked to supper, and when nobody asked he did not eat. Within a year the whole east side

called him Doc, and the west side did not call him anything, because on the west side his name was not said.

Ferdinand Kahn never spoke it again. When he had to, he said *that man.*

II. Julius

Mercury Street · 1918–1919

The son came down after him. That was the part the father could least forgive.

Julius Kahn was twenty-six and had been to Harvard for a year and had come home without saying why. In the spring of 1918 he walked down the hill one Sunday to see what his sister's husband was doing in the Cabbage Patch, and he stayed. He swept the floor. He boiled the instruments. He carried the bag when Matti was too sick to carry it. Through the winter of the influenza he worked beside Doc for nineteen hours a day, and the women of the Patch said he was nearly as good as Doc himself, and Julius heard them say it.

He was quick, and he had ideas. A real dispensary, brick, with beds. A ward for the consumptives. His father's money. His own name over the door, since his father's name was already over enough doors. Doc listened to all of it and said no. He said it gently, the way he said everything. He said the Patch did not need a building with anybody's name on it. It needed somebody to come when it called.

Julius did not take it gently. He went back up the hill in January 1919, and in February, when the company cut the wage by a dollar a day and the men walked out and the soldiers came in with bayonets, a good many of the names on the strike committee turned out to be names from the dispensary's ledger, men who had talked in their fevers, men who had told Doc what they thought of the company with a thermometer in their mouths. Their rustling cards were pulled. Without a rustling card no man could work a shift in any mine on the Hill. Some of them went to Bisbee. Some went to Seattle. Some stayed in the Patch and drank.

Doc never said one word against Julius Kahn. He said nothing at all, which was worse, because it was talked about.

Ferdinand Kahn sat in his office on the seventh floor and added it up. That man had taken his daughter and left her. That man had taken his son and made him into whatever he was now. Every time Kahn went up West Granite Street in his Pierce-Arrow and saw his grandson playing in the yard, the boy had that man's face.

III. The Street

North Main Street · a Friday in July, 1919

The state had gone dry at the end of December. Butte had not noticed. There were stills in kitchens all over the Hill and in half the cellars uptown, and in the Patch a man called the King sold whiskey out of a washtub at fifty cents a pint, and nobody in the city government drank any less than before, only more quietly.

Ferdinand Kahn drank on North Main Street, in the middle of the afternoon, sitting on a kitchen chair in the middle of the road.

He had found out from somebody that Doc was going to supper that Friday with the Trevorrows, a Cornish family on North Main whose youngest he had pulled through the influenza, and he had his driver bring the Pierce-Arrow up the hill and stop it crossways, and he had the driver carry out a chair from the car, and he sat in it with a fruit jar of the King's whiskey on his knee and his hat tipped back and waited. Ore wagons went around him. A streetcar stopped and rang its bell and could not go around him and stopped. Men came out of the saloons that were now called soft-drink parlors and stood in the doors to watch.

Doc came up the hill at half past five with Matti Lahti carrying the bag. Matti saw the chair first.

Mr. Kahn, said Matti, from twenty feet off. *It's the doctor coming.*

Tell him to go around.

Mr. Kahn. He's going to supper.

Tell him to go around. He's no better than I am. I don't step off the street for him.

Matti said it a third time, and the old man said it a third time, louder, so that the men in the doorways heard it and the motorman on the streetcar heard it, and he drank from the jar and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand and did not look at his son-in-law at all.

Doc looked at him for some while. Then he touched Matti's arm and turned around and went back down the hill the way he had come.

Kahn crooked a finger at a man in a grey suit who had been standing on the corner by the cigar store all afternoon. His name was Dunphy and he was a detective, the kind the company kept, and Kahn had kept him privately since February at a rate that Dunphy did not report to the company. *Go after him,* said Kahn. *Hear what he says.*

Dunphy went after him, a block behind, and then half a block, and then near enough.

Partway down North Main, Doc smiled. Matti saw it. In two years he had seen Doc smile perhaps a dozen times, and never at anything that anybody else thought was funny.

Why are you smiling, Doc?

Look at him, Matti.

Matti looked back up the hill, at the motorcar crossways in the road and the old man in the chair with the jar.

I see him.

He has done a hard thing today, said Doc. *Seven days from now, on the ground floor of his building, at the foot of the stairs, the ground is going to open and take him.*

He said it the way he said that a lung was clear or that a leg would have to come off, without any weight on it at all, and he went on down the hill to the Patch.

IV. The Seventh Floor

The Kahn Block, West Park Street · the same night

Dunphy told it to Kahn word for word in the office on the seventh floor, standing, with his hat in his hands.

Kahn did not laugh. He had known that man for seven years. He had seen what that man's diagnoses were worth uptown. When that man said a superintendent had a year, the superintendent had a year, to the week. When that man said a child would live, the child lived, and when he said it would not, the mother might as well go and see the undertaker. Kahn knew all this, and so he did not laugh. He sat in his leather chair and thought about it with his fingertips together, the way he had once thought about a shipment of Irish linen that was coming by way of Panama.

He didn't say seven days, he said at last. *He said seven days, on the ground floor, at the foot of the stairs. Those were his words?*

Those were his words.

Then I won't be on the ground floor, said Ferdinand Kahn. *And I won't be at the foot of the stairs. And in a week that man is a liar in front of the whole town.*

The next morning there was a card in the windows of Kahn's that said CLOSED FOR INVENTORY. By noon the brass bed from his house on Park Street had come up in the freight elevator to the seventh floor, and his Turkish carpet, and his Victrola, and his account books back to 1881, and a crate of bonded whiskey from before the war, and his wife's portrait, and a commode. Then he had the elevator man run the car up to seven and shut off the current and chain the gate. He had the carpenters come in on Saturday afternoon and take out the lowest flight of the grand staircase, the broad one of polished oak that went up from the main floor to the mezzanine, so that it ended in the air ten feet over the marble with nothing under it. He had the doors to the back stairs barred on every floor with iron straps through the handles. And he hired fourteen men, two for every floor, big men, and set them at the doors with chairs and a deck of cards and a jug of water, and paid them five dollars a day in advance, which was more than the company was paying underground.

They were miners, all fourteen. They were men who had lost their rustling cards in February. He did not know that. He had not asked their names.

If I forget myself, he told them, *and start down, you put me back. I don't care what I say. You put me back.*

Then he sat down in the leather chair by the window on the seventh floor, with the Hill spread out under him, the headframes and the dumps and the smoke going straight up in the still July air, and poured a glass of the bonded whiskey, and waited for the week to be over.

V. The Dispensary

Mercury Street · Sunday night

By Sunday the whole town had it. They had it in Dublin Gulch and in Meaderville and in Finntown, in the boardinghouses and the soft-drink parlors and the cribs on Venus Alley. There were bets in the cigar stores on Main Street, three to one against Kahn, and the odds got shorter every day.

The dispensary was full that night, as it was full every night. Men sat on the bench along the wall waiting to be listened to with the stethoscope, holding their caps, with the cough in them that came up out of the deep levels with the rock dust and never went back down. A Serbian woman sat on the floor with a baby with croup. An Irish widow from Corktown was there with her boy's broken arm. Two of the fourteen men from the Kahn Block were there, off shift, because they had been coming to Doc for their lungs since before February and saw no reason to stop. One of them told it. The iron straps. The stairs cut off ten feet up in the air. The elevator chained at seven.

Somebody laughed. Doc did not. He was listening to the Serbian baby's chest, with his head bent down close, and when he had finished listening he wrapped the baby up again and handed it back and said what to do with the kettle and the towel, and then he sat back on his stool and looked at the bench along the wall.

Let him go up seven floors, he said. *Let him go up in an aeroplane. Let him get on a ship at Seattle and go out to sea. Let him go down the Speculator to the bottom level and wall himself in. There's no place a man can go where it can't find him. There isn't any such place.*

Nobody said anything. The Serbian baby coughed.

Doc did not talk about religion. Nobody in the Patch had ever heard him say a prayer, though Matti said he lit a candle on Friday nights when he remembered, and stood looking at it for a long time. But he said this next thing in the voice of a man reading, and Matti said afterward that there was a Bible on the shelf over the cot, the new English one the Jewish Publication Society had brought out two years before, which Doc's mother had sent him from Chicago though she could not read it, and that it had been open that week to the herdsman Amos, who had said he was no prophet and no prophet's son.

> *Though they dig into the nether-world, thence shall My hand take them; and though they climb up to heaven, thence will I bring them down. And though they hide themselves in the top of Carmel, I will search and take them out thence; and though they be hid from My sight in the bottom of the sea, thence will I command the serpent, and he shall bite them.*
>
> *— Amos 9:2–3*

Then he called the next man on the bench.

The people who were in the dispensary that night did not forget it, and some of them were not the same afterward. A Cornish timberman named Pascoe, who had been drinking his pay at the King's washtub since February, went home that night and poured out what he had in the house and never bought from the King again. The Irish widow went to confession for the first time in eleven years. One of the fourteen men went back to the Kahn Block in the morning and sat down at his door on the fourth floor and took out the cards, and did not deal them, and sat the whole day with his hands still in his lap, looking down the light court at the marble floor, as if he were waiting for something that had already happened.

VI. The General

The Kahn Block · the seventh day

THE WEEK WENT BY ON THE SEVENTH FLOOR. KAHN READ HIS account books. He played the Victrola, Caruso and then Sousa and then Caruso again. He drank less of the bonded whiskey than he had meant to, and slept badly in the brass bed, and in the mornings he stood at the iron railing of the light court and looked down six floors at the main floor of his store, at the glass counters under their dust sheets and the oak staircase ending in the air, and counted the days. Sophie came once, on the Wednesday, and stood across the street on the sidewalk with the boy and looked up at the seventh floor windows. He did not go to the window. The guards played pinochle on the landings. Down below in the alley, in the stable behind the store where the last of the delivery horses were kept, his saddle horse stood in its box stall and was groomed twice a day and walked in the alley in the evening.

The horse was a tall dapple grey, seventeen hands, a Kentucky saddler that Kahn had bought in Louisville in 1910 and ridden at the head of every Fourth of July parade since. It had been called Kaiser until April of 1917, when it was no longer wise to call anything in Butte by that name, and then Kahn had renamed it the General, and the newspaper had made a joke of it, and Kahn had liked the joke.

On the afternoon of the seventh day, a Friday, at about four o'clock, a Ford truck backfired in the alley, and the General kicked out the door of his box stall and came through the freight entrance into the back of the store and onto the main floor.

The noise came up the light court like a rockslide in a mine. Glass. Iron. A sound like a gong where the General kicked the brass rail of the hosiery counter, and then the counter itself, and then another one. A guard on the third floor shouted. The guards on the seventh floor got up out of their chairs.

What is that, said Kahn. *What is it?*

It's your horse, Mr. Kahn. The General's loose on the main floor.

Kahn went to the railing of the light court and looked down. Six floors down, in the slant afternoon light from the glass roof, the big grey horse was turning in circles among the broken counters with its eyes white and its shod hooves sliding on the marble, and the silk scarves from the ladies' counter were blowing up around it in the wind it made like leaves. Then it raised its head and looked straight up the light court, through six floors of railing, at Ferdinand Kahn, and stood still.

It stood perfectly still. Its sides went in and out. It looked at him.

Kahn had raised that horse from a four-year-old. Nobody else had ever been able to catch it when it got loose, nobody in thirty years, only him. He said its name. He got up off the railing and went toward the door to the back stairs to go down and catch it, without thinking, the way you go to a child that has fallen.

The iron straps through the door handles fell out of their own accord and rang on the floor. The door swung open by itself. The two men at the door of the seventh floor, who had been paid five dollars a day in advance to put him back, took him by the collar of his coat, one on each side, and threw him down the stairs.

On the sixth floor the door was standing open when he got there, and the straps were on the floor, and the two men there took him by the neck and threw him down. On the fifth floor, the same. On the fourth floor the man who had sat all day with his hands in his lap stood up and did what the others did. On the third, the second, the mezzanine. And at the mezzanine the lowest flight of the grand staircase, the broad flight of polished oak the carpenters had sawed out and carried off on Saturday afternoon, was back in its place, every step of it, with the brass rods on the carpet, and he came down it all the way.

He landed on the marble at the foot of the stairs, on the ground floor, ten feet from his horse.

The floor opened under him. The witnesses did not agree afterward on much, but they all agreed that it did not crack or cave the way ground caves on the Hill, with a groan first and then dust. It opened, the way a mouth opens, the marble and the joists and the cellar under them and

whatever lay under that, and Ferdinand Kahn went down into it alive, without a sound, and it closed.

VII. The Rope

West Park Street · after

It did not close all the way. It left a hole at the foot of the grand staircase about the size of a grave, square-edged, with the cut ends of the marble showing white. The company sent engineers that evening. They lowered a lantern on a rope, a hundred feet and then two hundred, and the lantern went down past rock and old timbering and came to nothing they could see, and they pulled it up again. They said it must be an old working, a drift off some claim from the eighties that was never mapped, and that the whole Hill was hollow under Butte like a honeycomb and everybody knew it, and they wrote that down.

The old men who kept a minyan in a back room on East Galena Street, who had never liked Ferdinand Kahn and had never pretended to, said that the earth had opened its mouth for Korah too, in the wilderness, and that Korah had also been a rich man, and had also had a great deal to say about who should step aside for whom.

The fourteen men collected their five dollars for the seventh day and went back to the Patch. None of them would ever talk about it, except the one from the fourth floor, who said only that the door had opened and he had done what he was there to do.

Doc was in the dispensary on Mercury Street when Matti came to tell him. He was lancing a boil on a Finnish mucker's neck. He did not look up for some time. When he did, he said *all right, Matti,* and finished the boil, and wrote something in the ledger, and called the next man.

Sophie Brill came down to the store at dusk. The engineers had gone. There was nobody on the main floor but the night watchman and the horse. The General was standing where he had stood when he looked up the light court, at the edge of the hole, in the broken glass and the blown silk, with his head low. His halter rope had come loose from its ring and was hanging down over the cut edge of the marble into the dark, and he

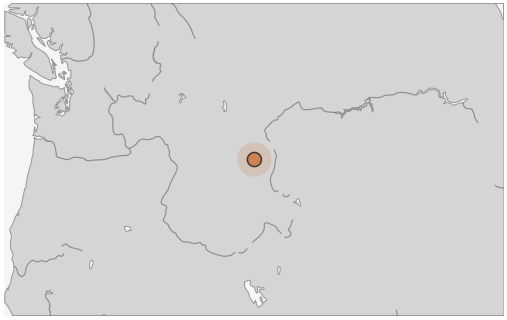
was standing very still above it, as a horse will stand when it has been told to wait.

Background

The verse

> *Not in the sky, not in the midst of the sea, not if we enter into the clefts of the mountains, is there known a spot in the whole world where death could not overcome (the mortal).*
>
> Dhammapada 128 (numbered 127 in the Project Gutenberg text), tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Sākyan noble Suppabuddha holds a grudge against the Buddha, who left Suppabuddha's daughter to go forth and later fell out with Suppabuddha's son, Devadatta. One day Suppabuddha sits drinking in the street to block the Buddha's way to a meal, and will not make way however many times he is asked. The Buddha turns back and smiles, and tells Ānanda that in seven days Suppabuddha will be swallowed by the earth at the foot of the stairway on the ground floor of his palace. Hearing this from a spy, Suppabuddha moves to the top of his seven-storied palace, has the stairway taken away and the doors barred, and sets strong men at every door with orders to turn him back. On the seventh day his state horse breaks loose below; he rises to catch it, the doors open, the stairways return, his own guards throw him down from floor to floor, and at the foot of the stairs the earth opens and takes him. Read the full commentary story, or about Suppabuddha and his son Devadatta.



Butte, Montana

Butte, 1917–1919

By the First World War, Butte sat on top of one of the richest copper deposits in the world, and most of its mines belonged to the Anaconda Company. On June 8, 1917, a fire in the Granite Mountain shaft spread through the connected tunnels of the Speculator Mine and killed 168 men, most of them suffocated; a few survived by sealing themselves behind makeshift bulkheads. To work at all, a miner needed a company-issued rustling card, which could be revoked at any time and served as a blacklist against union men. When copper prices fell after the war, the mine owners cut wages by a dollar a day, the miners struck in February 1919, and federal troops kept the city under occupation until the end of 1920. Montana's statewide prohibition took effect at the end of 1918, and Butte, which had voted against it, went on drinking out of kitchen stills.

Butte's Jewish community dated to 1875. Its merchants built some of the city's leading stores, among them Symons' department store on West Park Street, and its Reform temple, B'nai Israel, was dedicated in 1904 at Washington and Galena Streets. A few blocks east lay the Cabbage Patch, more than two hundred shanties between Mercury and Silver Streets, with no electricity or running water, where miners sometimes shared a bed in turns by shift. Underneath all of it the Hill was cut through with tunnels, and later in the century the ground over the old workings sank by as much as twelve feet across central Butte.

After the story of Suppabuddha the Sākyan from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 128). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society Tanakh (1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 10

Punishment

10.1

The Parking Chair

All that breathe
Will share thy destiny.
— William Cullen Bryant, "Thanatopsis"

The way they tell it up the street, on Nevada Avenue.

I. The Dig

Dormont, Pennsylvania · Sunday, March 14, 1993

It started to snow on Friday night, and all day Saturday it came down two and three inches an hour, with thunder in it. Downtown they held the St. Patrick's parade anyway. By dark there were two feet on the ground in Dormont and the Turnpike was shut. Sunday came up blue and bitter, with a wind. The borough plow reached Nevada Avenue about nine and did what a plow does on a street of parked cars. It opened one lane down the middle and laid a wall against every car on the block, chest high and packed like concrete.

Nevada Avenue is brick foursquares shoulder to shoulder, built in the twenties for men who rode the streetcar to work, and not one of them has a driveway. Parking is on the even side. There had been a custom about that for longer than most people on the street had been alive. You dug out your space, you stood a kitchen chair in it, and it was yours until the street was bare. Nobody had ever written it down.

The houses at 1245 and 1247 had been cut into apartments, and that winter seventeen people lived in them, none over thirty-one. There were four nursing students, two boys from the Art Institute, a line cook, two brothers from Altoona who hung drywall, and a respiratory therapist named Jim Otto who came from wheat country in eastern Washington

and had not heard of a parking chair before that fall. They had been shut in together since Friday with the same four videotapes. At ten on Sunday morning all seventeen came out with five shovels, a coal scoop from the cellar, two dustpans and a cookie sheet, and dug the whole frontage of both houses, six car lengths, down to the brick. It took them until two. They had no chairs to spare. They stood a laundry basket, a milk crate and a floor lamp along the curb and went in to eat.

The Leskos lived at 1251 and 1253 and had since 1951. There were six Lesko men who counted: Stan, who was fifty-eight, his brother Ray, Stan's two sons, a son-in-law and a nephew. They ran a paving business, and in winter they hung plows on three pickups and cleared lots. They had been out since Saturday noon without sleep, doing a supermarket, two churches and a bank. At three on Sunday they came up Nevada Avenue in a line and found their own curb under the plow wall and, two doors down, six clean spaces with a floor lamp in one of them.

Ray Lesko set the lamp on the sidewalk.

The seventeen came out on the porches, and then down the steps.

We dug that, said one of the nursing students. Her name was Dawn Kubiak. *It took us four hours.*

We're on this street forty-two years, Stan Lesko said. *You're here since September. That's our curb.*

We were here first this morning.

It went the way those things go. Somebody put the lamp back. A Lesko son shoved him. Then Ray swung the flat of a grain shovel into the side of a boy's head. The boy was an art student from Erie named Tim Fahey, twenty years old, and he sat down in the street with blood running out of his nose onto the snow. After that there were shovels up on both sides, and the Leskos were the ones who knew how to use them. The nephew got Dawn Kubiak by the back of her coat, put her face down in the plow wall and leaned on her. She could not lift her head. She could not get air. The ones who could scream screamed, and it carried the length of Nevada Avenue between the brick fronts.

II. The Porch

The same afternoon

Mrs. Haney lived at 1249, between them. She was eighty-one. She had come to that house as a bride in 1936, and nothing on the street was older except the sycamores. She had been at her front window since the trucks pulled up.

She came out on the porch in her husband's car coat and a pair of galoshes, with nothing on her head.

What was that?

She did not have a big voice. But everybody on Nevada Avenue under the age of sixty had at one time or another been sent to her door with a covered dish or a snow shovel, and they stopped. The nephew let go of the coat. The girl came up out of the snow with her mouth wide open.

The young ones told her, all at once. The Leskos looked at their shovels.

Stanley, said Mrs. Haney. *Put it down.*

He put it down.

Nobody raises a hand to anybody on this street. Not a hand and not a shovel. Not over a parking place, and not over anything else.

Mrs. Haney, with respect. Stan Lesko was breathing hard. Four winters before he had had his chest opened at Mercy Hospital, and he had just spent twenty-seven hours in a truck. *We got forty-two years here. That has to count.*

I was fifteen years on this street the day your father backed his truck up to that house, Stanley, and you were a boy carrying lamps. So you can leave off telling me about years. She came down one step and took hold of the rail. Behind her on the porch, where it waited every winter, stood a chrome kitchen chair with a red seat. *You think that chair is about a parking space. This whole street has thought so since Truman, and I let you.*

Nobody had parked in front of 1249 with snow on the ground in forty-three winters. She had not owned a car since 1951.

Thanksgiving of 1950 it snowed three days. Thirty inches. They had tanks out pushing it. On the Sunday morning Walter went down with the coal shovel

to get the Plymouth out for Monday. He was thirty-eight years old. He ran the 42 car and had never been sick a day. He cleared the space down to the brick, square at the corners, and stood the shovel in the bank, and lay down. I watched him do it from that window. I thought he was fooling.

I took a kitchen chair out and sat by him. It was four o'clock before they could get anybody up the hill. I didn't know a prayer that was long enough. So I said him a piece Miss Kearns made us get by heart in the eighth grade, because it was the longest thing I had.

Nobody moved. She said some of it to the street then, holding the rail, without hurry, the way she had been taught to say it.

> *So shalt thou rest—and what, if thou withdraw*
> *Unheeded by the living, and no friend*
> *Take note of thy departure? All that breathe*
> *Will share thy destiny.*
>
> *— William Cullen Bryant, "Thanatopsis"*

That's whose space that is, she said. *He dug it. I put the chair in it every snow so I'd remember there is one place apiece kept for us, and nobody has to fight to get it.*

She looked at Stan Lesko.

I watched you get down out of that truck, Stanley. You stood with your hand flat on your chest before you ever reached for the shovel. I know what you were listening for. That girl with her face in the bank was listening for the very same thing, and so was that boy. There is nobody standing in this street who is afraid of anything you aren't. So that is the end of the hitting.

She went in and shut the door, because she was cold.

By then Jim Otto had the Fahey boy sitting up against a tire. He tipped the boy's head forward, pinched his nose shut and held it. A school bus driver had done that for him once, when he was six. One of Stan's sons went into 1251 and came back with a bag of frozen peas, and stood holding it until somebody took it from him.

The trucks spent that night in the bank lot on West Liberty Avenue.

III. The Brick

Nevada Avenue · afterward

After that it was simply how Nevada Avenue was. You could chair a space you had dug, and you could not lay a hand on anybody. People who moved onto the street were told both things the first time it snowed, and as a rule it was a Lesko who told them. The next winter the complaints about chairs got so bad across the borough that the Dormont police went around and took them out of two hundred spaces. They say the officer who worked Nevada Avenue took every chair on the block but one.

That was later. On the Monday morning Mrs. Haney came to her window at six, as she always did. The wind had dropped. Five kitchen chairs stood along the curb at 1245 and 1247, no two alike. In front of 1251 a pickup was nosed in behind a chair she knew from Stan Lesko's own kitchen. And in front of her house, where the plow wall had stood as high as the porch rail when she went to bed, a space had been cut down to the brick, square at the corners, long enough for a Plymouth. The red chair stood in the middle of it.

She never did find out which of them dug it. A little new snow had come in the night, and it lay on the seat.

Background

The verse

> *All men tremble at punishment, all men fear death; remember that you are like unto them, and do not kill, nor cause slaughter.*
>
> Dhammapada 129, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The Group of Six are the standing troublemakers of the monastic rule. In this story the younger Group of Seventeen have made a lodging ready, and the Six arrive and say, *We are older; this belongs to us.* The Seventeen answer, *We will not give it to you; we were the first to make it ready.* The Six strike them, and the Seventeen, in fear of death, scream at the top of their lungs. The Buddha hears the outcry, asks what it was, and lays down the rule against striking a blow. Then he says that a person should reflect

that others tremble at the rod and fear death just as he does, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story. The next story in the commentary is its sequel, in which the Six raise their hands again.

Dormont, Pennsylvania

Dormont and the parking chair, *1993*

Dormont is a borough of less than a square mile, four miles south of downtown Pittsburgh, that filled with houses when the streetcar tunnel opened the South Hills. It holds more than ten thousand people to the square mile, and a great many of its houses have no driveway. The parking chair is the custom, strongest in and around Pittsburgh, of marking a street space you have shoveled out with a kitchen or lawn chair. It has no standing in law and is generally honored anyway; photographs of it go back at least to the 1950s. In 1994, according to press accounts, the Dormont police removed the markers from some two hundred spaces after too many complaints. Nevada Avenue and everyone on it are invented.

The storm of March 12–14, 1993, left about twenty-five inches in Pittsburgh, 23.6 of them on Saturday the thirteenth, at two to three inches an hour; the downtown St. Patrick's Day parade went ahead that day, and the Turnpike and most roads were closed. The Thanksgiving-weekend storm of 1950 left about thirty inches, and tanks were used to help clear it. William Cullen Bryant drafted "Thanatopsis" as a very young man in western Massachusetts, and it was first printed in 1817; generations of American schoolchildren learned it by heart. The lines here follow the text of his collected *Poems*. The poem ends by asking its hearer to go to the grave not "like the quarry-slave at night, / Scourged to his dungeon," but as one who lies down to sleep.

After the story of the Group of Six from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 129). The original. The poem is William Cullen Bryant's "Thanatopsis" (1817). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

10.2

Rule Two

> *The sixth commandment forbiddeth the taking away of our own life, or the life of our neighbour unjustly, or whatsoever tendeth thereunto.*
> — *Westminster Shorter Catechism, Q. 69*

As it was passed along to me, at the elevator in Oakesdale.

I. The Gum

Whitman County, Washington · September 1968

Lois Kincaid drove the north route for the Oakesdale school, forty-four miles of gravel and two of blacktop, and she had driven it since the fall of 1961, when the district bought a second bus and nobody else applied. She was out of the yard at ten to seven. She came back at a quarter past eight with forty-one children, or forty if one of the Hoffs had an earache, and she knew every one of them by the back of the head.

The bus was a 1959 Chevrolet with a Wayne body, and it had a long mirror over the windshield, a strip of glass the width of the aisle and a little more, bent so that it held the whole bus at once. In it Lois could see forty-one children and the gray ribbon of road going away behind them out the back door. It was the first thing she looked at after the road and the last thing before it. She did not need to turn around. Children thought she had an eye in the back of her head, and she let them.

The hills that year were already worked down for fall seeding when school began, brown and smooth as the side of a loaf, and so steep in places that the Rademachers ran a combine that leveled itself on the slope like a man leaning into a wind. Out the left-hand windows on the

north leg you saw Steptoe Butte all morning, the only thing in that country that was rock instead of dirt. On a clear day she could see Mount Spokane, fifty-odd miles off, and on those mornings she said to the windshield, *Well, there it is,* as if it might not have been.

Her son Danny had ridden this bus from first grade through his senior year, and then gone a year and a half to Washington State in Pullman and drawn houses in the margins of his engineering notes and come home. The draft board had him by Easter. He went over in July, to a place he spelled out carefully in his first letter so she could find it on the map at the library, in a river delta south of Saigon where he said everything was wet, his socks and his paper and his cigarettes. The letters came every week or ten days. Where the stamp should go he wrote FREE, in the small square capitals he had learned in mechanical drawing, and she kept them in the glove compartment of the bus in a rubber band, in order.

The first week of school she walked down the aisle of the bus after her morning run, as she did every day, to look for mittens and lunch sacks, and she put her hand on the back seat and took it away. The vinyl had been green once. Under the last two benches, where the big kids had sat since Eisenhower, the gum was laid on in layers like the strata in a road cut, pink and gray and black, and somebody had pressed a row of pennies into it.

That afternoon she stood up in the aisle before the first stop.

Those back two seats are a disgrace, she said. *Whoever cleans them can have them. For the year.*

The big kids got on last, on the Elberton road, and so did not hear it. The little kids got on first, on the long loop past the Pfaff place and down along the creek, and they heard every word. Becky Pfaff was eleven, the oldest of five, and she organized it. On Friday after school seventeen of them, Pfaffs and Hoffs and Lindemans and the Coulter twins and the two little Ottos and some others, stayed in the bus in the school yard with butter knives and a putty knife from the shop and a coffee can of hot water from the janitor, and they scraped. Lois sat in the driver's seat and graded nothing and watched in the mirror. It took them an hour and

twenty minutes. The Otto boy who was six found the pennies and kept them.

On Monday the seventeen sat in the back. They sat three and four to a bench, knees up, with the clean green vinyl under them, and they were so pleased that nobody talked.

The big boys got on at the Rademacher mailbox. There were six of them who sat together, Gary Rademacher and his cousin Neil, the two Dorman brothers, Mike Schultz and a tall boy named Pete Varney who did whatever Gary did, and they were juniors and seniors and had sat in the back since they were freshmen, as the big ones before them had, as Danny had. They came down the aisle with their letter jackets open and stopped.

Move, said Gary.

We cleaned it, said Becky Pfaff. *She said whoever cleaned it.*

We're seniors. It's ours.

We were first, said Becky.

Lois had slowed for the railroad crossing below the Dorman place. She stopped short of the track, as the law said, and pulled the door lever and opened the door to listen, as the law also said, for a train you could not see. What she heard instead came from behind her. It was children screaming, the real kind. She looked up into the mirror. There were letter jackets in the back of it and small arms over small heads, and against the back window one of the Otto boys was holding his face, and there was blood on the glass.

She shut the door and set the brake and turned the key off, and the bus went quiet except for the Otto boy.

She walked back. She had never been a tall woman.

What was that?

They told her, all at once, the little ones. The big boys did not say anything. Neil Rademacher was looking at his own knuckles. Lois took the clean handkerchief out of her coat pocket and tipped Jimmy Otto's head forward and pinched his nose for him and held it.

Nobody hits anybody on this bus, she said. *Not ever. Not for a seat.* She looked at Gary Rademacher, whom she had driven to first grade. *You were*

six once. Somebody bigger than you sat where they wanted. You remember what that was like. Everybody's scared of that. Everybody is.

She sent the six of them to the middle of the bus and they went. She held Jimmy Otto's nose until it stopped. Then she walked back up the aisle, started the bus, looked both ways at the empty track, and crossed it.

That night she made a card. She did it at the kitchen table after Walt had gone to bed, on the back of a cut-down calendar page, with Danny's T-square from his room so the lines would be straight, because he had left it there leaning against the drafting board and she had not moved either one. She lettered it as plainly as she could. RULES OF BUS 2. And under it: 1. NOBODY HITS ANYBODY. In the morning she taped it up above the windshield beside the mirror, where the whole bus could see it. Nobody said a word about it. It held.

II. Bang

The Elberton road · November 1968

It held through football. It held through the election, which the bus argued about for a week in the voices of its fathers, and through the first hard frost, when she let the engine run twenty minutes in the yard before seven so the heater would have a chance, and the heater still only warmed the first four rows. The big boys sat in the middle where it was warmer and said that was why. The little ones sat in the back in their snowsuits and bounced over the axle on the washboard and liked it.

Danny wrote that they had been moving around a good deal and that he was fine. He asked whether his dad had got the winter wheat in before the rain. He asked whether she was still driving the old crate, and said to tell whoever was in the back seat now that it was the best seat on the bus, because of the bounce.

Gary Rademacher would be eighteen on the ninth of December. Everybody on the bus knew it, because his mother had told everybody at church, the way you tell people about an operation. His older brother Ron was a Marine and had been at a place in the north of the country all

spring that had been on the television, and had come home in October and was living in the bunkhouse and did not come up to the house for supper. Gary had stopped going out for basketball. He sat on the aisle in the middle of the bus with his knees against the seat in front of him and pushed, so that the seat moved, and whoever was in it moved, and there was no rule about that.

The morning it happened there was the first real snow, three inches, dry, blowing across the road in long white snakes, and she had the chains on. The six got on at the Rademacher mailbox already in a mood that she could see in the mirror. It started with Neil reaching back over the seat and flicking a Lindeman girl's ear, and it went from there, a knee here, a knuckle, a hat pulled off and thrown, and none of it quite what the card said, until one of the Dormans reached back and caught Becky Pfaff by her braid and pulled her head down hard against the top of the seat.

Then the seventeen stood up.

They stood on the benches in the back in their snowsuits, every one of them, the six-year-olds and Becky with her hand on her head, and they put out their arms with their first fingers straight and their thumbs cocked, and they shot the six. They shot them all together. *Bang. Bang. Bang. You're dead. You're dead, you're dead, you're all dead.* They had watched war on the television their whole lives and they knew how. They made the noise in the backs of their throats that a rifle makes on the television, and the little Otto boy made the noise of the machine gun on the jeep, and they did not stop.

She was at the top of the hill above the creek. She put her foot on the brake too hard and the bus slewed on the chains and came round a little sideways and stopped, and in the mirror forty-one children went forward against the seat backs and came back. Nobody was hurt.

She did not get up right away. She sat with both her hands on the wheel. The children could see her face in the long mirror, as she could see theirs, and the bus got very quiet, and she let it. Then she set the brake and turned off the key and went back.

We didn't hit, said Becky Pfaff before she got there. *You said nobody hits. We didn't touch anybody.* Her eyes were wet from the braid. *They started it.*

I know they did.

We didn't hit, said one of the Coulter twins.

No. She stood in the aisle between the six and the seventeen with her hand on the back of a seat. *Sit down. All of you sit down.*

They sat down. The Otto boy was still holding his finger out, not pointing it at anybody now, as if he did not know where to put it.

Who goes to catechism? she said.

Seven or eight hands went up, Presbyterians and Lutherans, and a Catholic or two, who had their own. Becky Pfaff's hand went up. Lois nodded at her.

The sixth commandment, said Lois. *What is required.*

Becky said it in the singsong in which it had been given to her, and Lois had been given it at the same age, in a church basement in 1931, from the same small blue book. Then Lois said the next one herself, the answer to what is forbidden, slowly, so that the Catholics could follow it.

> *The sixth commandment requireth all lawful endeavours to preserve our own life, and the life of others.*
>
> *The sixth commandment forbiddeth the taking away of our own life, or the life of our neighbour unjustly, or whatsoever tendeth thereunto.*
>
> *— Westminster Shorter Catechism, Q. 68–69*

What's tendeth? said the Coulter twin.

Leans that way, said Lois. *Anything that leans that way.* She took the Otto boy's hand, the one he was still holding out, and folded the finger down into it, and the thumb, and gave it back to him. *That.*

Then she turned around so that she was looking at the six. Gary Rademacher had his eyes on the floor.

Every one of you on this bus wants to get home tonight, she said. *Every one. You want it, and so does he, and so does she. It's the same thing in all of you. Look at him and you know what he wants. He wants what you want.*

She did not say anything about her son. She did not need to. Every family on the route knew where he was. The Lindemans had sent him cookies.

She went back up the aisle and sat down. She took the card down from over the windshield, and got the pencil off the visor, and wrote under the first rule, as straight as she could without the T-square, against the steering wheel: 2. NOBODY POINTS ANYTHING AT ANYBODY. She taped it back up. Then she started the bus, backed it off the shoulder, and drove the rest of the way to Oakesdale in second gear. Nobody said a word. In the mirror forty-one children sat with their hands in their laps like people in church.

III. The Mailbox

The Rademacher mailbox · May 1969

GARY REGISTERED ON THE TENTH OF DECEMBER, THE DAY after his birthday, at the board in Colfax, and his mother told everybody. He went back out for basketball after Christmas and did not make it all the way back in shape, and he sat on the bench and was the one who went in to foul. At some point in the winter he moved up a seat, and then another, until he was sitting in the second row behind Lois, where the heat was, and he talked to her, mostly about the Rademachers' combine and whether a man could get on at the elevator, and once, only once, in March, about his brother in the bunkhouse, who he said had stopped sleeping.

Danny wrote that he was being moved to a desk in a base camp to draw maps, which he called the luckiest thing that had ever happened to anybody, and after that his letters were longer and had drawings in them. One was of the long mirror, from memory, with forty-one heads in it, and a little square up in the corner for the card he had heard about, with two lines in it too small to read. She kept it in the glove compartment with the rest.

The card stayed where it was. Nobody hit anybody on Bus 2 that year, and nobody pointed anything at anybody. By spring it was simply how things were on that bus, as the gum had been before. The seventeen kept the back. In May, when the peas came up in rows so fine you could see

them from Steptoe like the lines on a ruled tablet, Becky Pfaff let the two little Ottos have the corner by the window, because of the bounce.

The last day of school was a Friday, warm, with the windows down. She let the seniors off first that afternoon, as she always did, at their own mailboxes, a long way round, and when they got to the Rademachers' she pulled over and opened the door. Gary got off with his cap and gown in a dry-cleaning bag over his shoulder, walked down into the ditch and up the other side to the mailbox, and stood there.

She shut the door. She looked in the mirror before she pulled out, the way she always did, and saw him in it, standing by the mailbox in the long gray ribbon of road behind the bus, and saw him lift his hand.

He held it up with the palm open, high, the way you hold your hand up to a tractor across a field. In the back window, all at once, the seventeen came up off their seats onto their knees and put their hands flat against the glass, all their palms, the six-year-olds and the Lindemans and Becky Pfaff, so many small hands that she could not see out the back for them, and could not see Gary, and then could see him again between their fingers as the road went down toward the creek, getting smaller, with his hand still up.

Lois took her left hand off the wheel and held it up too, open, to the mirror, where all of them could see it.

Background

The verse

> *All men tremble at punishment, all men love life; remember that thou art like unto them, and do not kill, nor cause slaughter.*
>
> Dhammapada 130, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The Group of Six are the troublemakers of the monastic rule, the monks whose misconduct prompts one regulation after another. In the story just before this one, they come upon lodgings that the younger Group of Seventeen have made ready, say *We are older; this belongs to us,* and beat them out of it, and the Buddha, hearing the screams, forbids striking. This story is the sequel. The Six strike the Seventeen again, and this time the Seventeen answer with threatening gestures, raising their

hands as if to strike back. The Buddha hears the outcry, asks what it is, and forbids the threatening gesture too, saying that a monk should consider that others tremble at the rod and hold life dear just as he does, and so should neither strike nor kill. Read the full commentary story, and the one before it.

Oakesdale, Washington

The Palouse, 1968

The Palouse of southeastern Washington is a country of steep, rolling hills built of wind-blown silt, almost all of it plowed for wheat and legumes since the 1880s; it is now the most important lentil-growing region in the country. Above it stands Steptoe Butte, a quartzite island about a thousand feet higher than the hills around it and some twelve miles north of Colfax, from which Mount Spokane can be seen seventy miles away. Oakesdale, named for a railroad official, is a small wheat town in Whitman County with its own school. Lois Kincaid, her route, Bus 2 and all the families on it are invented.

The Westminster Shorter Catechism, completed in 1647, was written to teach children the Reformed faith in 107 questions and answers, and generations of Presbyterian children learned it by heart. In 1968 the war in Vietnam reached its worst year for Americans: the National Archives counts 16,899 U.S. military deaths with a date in that year, more than in any other. Young men registered for the draft at eighteen with their local boards, and the war came into rural living rooms every night on the television news.

After the story of the Group of Six from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 130). The original. Scripture from the Westminster Shorter Catechism (1647). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.3

Bull Snake

> *That among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.*
> *— The Declaration of Independence*

Way I heard it told, on the river bar below White Bird.

I. The Reading

Salmon River, Idaho County, Idaho · June 1995

Every morning of the muster they ran the flag up a lodgepole on the Hollister bar at seven, and Orval Pruitt read to them. Orval was seventy-three and had been a gunner's mate on a destroyer off Okinawa, and he read in the voice he used at the Grange for the minutes, from a pocket Constitution the size of a deck of cards that had the Declaration in the front. He never read the whole thing. He read down to the part about Safety and Happiness and closed it, and the men said *amen* or nothing, and the women went back to the cook tent, and the boys went back to whatever they had been doing before somebody made them stand still.

There were nineteen families that year on the bar, which belonged to Dale Hollister and ran a quarter mile along the river below the town, cheatgrass and hackberry and basalt, hot by ten in the morning. They called themselves the Camas Prairie Volunteers. They met the second Tuesday at the Grange hall in Grangeville. They had started in the fall of 1992, after what happened to the Weaver family up at Ruby Ridge, which was in the same state and close enough to drive to, and they had grown after Waco. Most of them had worked in the woods or at the mills, or had cattle on Forest Service allotments, and they had watched the mills close and the allotments shrink since the salmon were listed, in a county where

the government owned most of the ground. They drilled. They kept food. They took a first aid course. They said, among themselves, that they would never be the ones to start anything.

Then on the nineteenth of April, the second anniversary of the fire at Waco, a man parked a truck in front of the federal building in Oklahoma City.

At the May meeting at the Grange, three men said the government had done it to itself so it could come for people like them. Two men said nothing. Della Kuehn stood up, which she did not often do, and said that she was a nurse and had watched it all night in the break room at the hospital, and that there had been a day care in that building, and that she would not stand in a room with anybody who thought there was a reason good enough. Then she sat down. After a while Orval Pruitt said he would not either. Two families did not come back. The rest came to the river in June.

II. The Woodpile

The Hollister bar · the third morning

THERE WERE ELEVEN BOYS ON THE BAR THAT YEAR BETWEEN eight and fourteen, and they ran in a pack, the way boys on a river do. Cody Hollister was thirteen and in charge of them because the bar was his father's. They had wooden rifles Dale had cut on the bandsaw, and the men let them drill at the back of the line in the mornings, and the rest of the day they were in the river or under the cook tent or up in the rocks looking for arrowheads they were not supposed to keep.

Jesse Ward's little brother found the snake. He was five, and he went to get kindling for his mother from the woodpile behind the cook tent and came back without any, white, and would not say why. Jesse went to look. Then all of them went.

It lay along the bottom log in the shade, as long as Cody was tall, yellow-brown with dark blotches down its back. When the boys came close it pulled itself into a loose coil and lifted its head and made the head go wide and flat, and it hissed, a long hard breath like a tire going down, and

it shook its tail in the dry hackberry leaves under the pile so that they buzzed.

Rattler, Jesse said. Nobody had to say it.

Cody sent Travis for the shovel. The others got sticks from the woodpile itself, split pine and a length of old fence rail, and the Moffatt twins got tent stakes, and they made a ring around the end of the pile the way they had seen their fathers make a perimeter. Cody was scared. They all were. That was why they did it fast. The first blow missed and hit the log and the snake struck at the stick, and the next blows did not miss. It writhed and threw itself against the logs and tried to go under them, and the shovel came down on its back a third of the way from the head, and it stopped trying to go anywhere and only moved there, slowly, in the leaves, with its mouth open.

III. The Medic

The same morning

Della made rounds every morning on the bar with a green tackle box full of bandages. She was forty-seven and worked nights in the emergency room at the hospital in Grangeville, and on the river she went from camp to camp after breakfast the way she went from bed to bed: blisters, sunburn, a fishhook in a thumb, a toddler with an ear, ticks. She was coming back from the river with the five-gallon jug on her shoulder when she saw the ring of boys at the woodpile and heard the shovel hit.

She set the jug down.

What are you doing?

Killing a rattler, Cody said. He did not look at her. He was breathing hard.

Why?

It was going to bite somebody. It was going to bite Jesse's little brother. Some of the others said it too, all at once. *It hissed at him. It rattled. We were scared it was going to bite.*

Della came through the ring and knelt down in the leaves. She took the length of fence rail out of the youngest boy's hands without asking and slid the end of it under the snake, gently, and lifted the front half of it up off the ground into the light where they could see. It did not strike. It hung over the rail with its mouth open.

Look at its eye, she said. *Round. A rattler's got a slit like a cat. Look at its tail.* She turned the rail. The tail tapered to a point, plain, like the end of a whip. There was nothing on it. *No rattle. That was leaves.*

It buzzed, said one of the twins.

It shook its tail in the dry leaves to make you think it was a rattler. It flattened its head out to look like a rattler. It hissed. It did everything it knew how to make you think it was the one thing in this canyon you're scared of. She looked around at them. *That's a bull snake. Gopher snake. It eats whistle pigs and mice out of your dad's feed shed. It couldn't hurt you if it tried. It was scared of you.*

Nobody said anything. On the river a drift boat went by with its oars shipped, people in it laughing.

You know what Orval reads every morning, Della said. *You stand there for it. Say it.*

They mumbled. She made them say it again, all of them, the eleven of them kneeling or standing in the hackberry leaves around a snake with its back broken, and they knew it by heart, because they had heard it every morning of their lives on that bar and at the Grange.

> *We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.*
>
> *— The Declaration of Independence, 1776*

It says men, Cody said. *It doesn't say snakes.*

No, it doesn't, Della said. *But you look at that thing and tell me what it was doing under there. It was pursuing its happiness. Same as you.* She was quiet a moment. *Everybody that ever hurt anything was after their own safety and happiness. Everybody. You won't ever get yours that way. I don't know why, but you*

won't. I've watched people try for twenty-five years. Leave the thing alone that wants to live, same as you, and maybe yours comes to you. That's all I know.

Cody was looking at the shovel in his hands as if somebody had handed it to him while he was asleep.

Like the one in Oklahoma, he said. *He thought they were coming for him.*

Della did not answer that. She stood up with the snake still hanging over the end of the rail and carried it, slow, out past the woodpile and up the slope to where the basalt broke into a rockslide, and laid the rail down among the rocks and tipped it, and the snake slid off into a crack between two stones. It went in a little at a time, crooked where the shovel had hit it, until the tail went in.

She came back and put the rail on the woodpile, and picked up her jug, and went on to the cook tent to see about the Moffatt baby's ear.

IV. Whistle Pigs

The Hollister bar · the last day

On the last afternoon of every muster the men drove up onto the benches above the river where the ground squirrels lived and shot whistle pigs, which was what everybody in Idaho County called them, for the noise they made. It was not training. It was the fun part. The boys had always gone, and the older ones shot.

That year the boys stayed down at the bar. Cody went to his father and said they would rather set up cans on the rocks by the river, and Dale Hollister looked at his son for a while and said that was fine, and asked why, and Cody did not know how to say it, so he said *just because*. Some of the men laughed about it in the trucks going up. Orval Pruitt did not go up that year either. He sat in a lawn chair by the river and watched the boys knock the cans off the rocks with a .22, one at a time, and set them back up, and when Jesse's little brother wanted to go up to the rockslide to look for the snake, Orval told him it was resting and to let it be.

Nobody on the bar could have said what was different about the eleven of them after that. Their mothers noticed it before their fathers did. They were quieter about some things. None of them, as far as anybody knew,

ever again killed a thing because they were frightened of it, though most of them hunted all their lives and several went into the service.

The Camas Prairie Volunteers met at the Grange for two more years. Fewer came each month. By the end it was mostly Orval and the coffee, and when Orval died his pocket Constitution went to Della, who kept it in the green tackle box.

V. The Kink

Deer Creek road above the Salmon · May 2010

Cody Hollister went to work for Idaho Fish and Game when he was twenty-four. He was a conservation officer out of Lewiston, and a good part of his summers was snakes: rattlers in garages, rattlers under porches, gopher snakes in chicken coops, and calls from frightened people who were sure the snake in the yard was a rattler and had a hoe in their hands when he got there. He went to every one of those calls. He carried a long hook in the truck and a lidded bucket, and he always looked at the eye first, and then at the tail, and he talked to the people the whole time in a low voice.

In May of 2010 he was driving the gravel road up out of the canyon above the old bar, which his father had sold, when he saw a snake lying across the road in the sun.

He stopped the truck. It was a gopher snake, the biggest he had ever seen, yellow-brown with dark blotches, and a third of the way down its back from the head it had a kink in it, an old bend where the spine had healed crooked. It lay there on the warm gravel a long while, not minding him. A gopher snake might live fifteen years in the wild. He knew that. He had looked it up more than once.

It could not have been the same one. He sat in the truck with the engine running and waited anyway, until it moved, and crossed the rest of the road in its own time, crooked where the shovel had hit it, and went into the rocks on the uphill side a little at a time, until the tail went in.

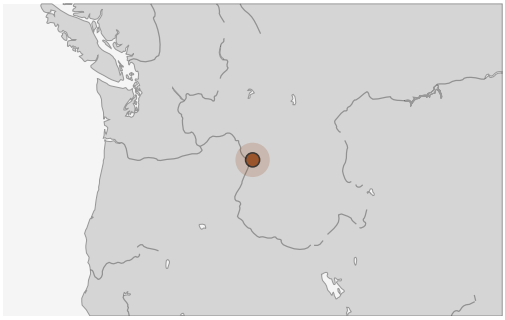
Background

The verses

> *He who seeking his own happiness punishes or kills beings who also long for happiness, will not find happiness after death.*
>
> Dhammapada 131, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who seeking his own happiness does not punish or kill beings who also long for happiness, will find happiness after death.*
>
> Dhammapada 132, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha is walking into Sāvatthī for alms when he sees a company of boys beating a house snake with a stick. He asks what they are doing, and why. They say they are afraid it will bite them. He tells them that whoever strikes another to make himself happy will not find happiness, and that those who seek happiness for themselves should not strike others, and he speaks the two verses. At the end of the teaching the boys enter the stream, the first stage of awakening. Read the full commentary story; the same incident is told in the Udāna (2.3).



White Bird, Idaho

Idaho, *1995*

The armed citizen militias of the 1990s grew out of two standoffs with federal agents: the 1992 siege at Ruby Ridge in northern Idaho, in which Randy Weaver's wife and son were killed, and the 1993 siege at Waco, Texas. By the mid-1990s there were militia groups in all fifty states. On April 19, 1995, the second anniversary of the fire at Waco, the Oklahoma City bombing killed 168 people, nineteen of them children, many in the day care center in the Alfred P. Murrah Federal Building. The attention that followed split many groups, and on June 15, 1995, a Senate Judiciary subcommittee held a hearing on the militia movement. The Camas Prairie Volunteers are invented.

The gopher snake, also called the bull snake, is Idaho's largest snake. When threatened it flattens its head, hisses, and shakes its tail in dry leaves so that it sounds like a rattlesnake, and Idaho Fish and Game notes that many are killed for it; it has round pupils and no rattle, eats rodents including ground squirrels, and may live about fifteen years in the wild. Gopher snakes and western rattlesnakes share the hot, low canyons of west-central Idaho, where a survey of Hells Canyon in 1995–1999 found them among the commonest reptiles. The Declaration is quoted from the National Archives transcription.

After the story of a company of boys from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 131 and 132). The original. Scripture from the Declaration of Independence. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.4

Two Coffees

> *For lack of wood the fire goeth out; And where there is no whisperer, contention ceaseth.*
> *— Proverbs 26:20*

I heard it testified, out at the old Walmart on the bypass.

I. Two Coffees

Anderson County, South Carolina · spring 2015

Open Field Church bought the Walmart on the bypass in 2009, a year after the store moved two miles up the road to a Supercenter, and by 2015 three thousand people came there on a Sunday. They kept the polished concrete floor and the long fluorescent bays and the loading dock. They put the sanctuary where the groceries had been, the children's wing in Lawn and Garden, and a coffee bar called the Grounds in the corner where the Subway used to be. Out front, above the doors, you could still see where the old letters had come down: a paler place on the block wall, in the shape of the name, that no paint quite covered. The new sign hung under it.

Caleb Pruitt was hired as youth pastor in January. He was twenty-seven and had grown up nine miles away in Cane Creek, an old mill village whose mill had shut when he was in the fourth grade. He had wanted to be a youth pastor since he was fourteen, and he was good at it in the quiet way, the kind who remembered the name of your dog and drove you home from Wednesday night when your mama's car broke down. He still wore the silver ring he had been given at thirteen, the night he signed a pledge card on the altar of Cane Creek First Baptist. He was not married.

He did not date. He said he was waiting on the Lord about it, and nobody laughed at him, because of the way he said it.

From the week he was hired, there was a girl with him.

He never saw her. Everybody else did. She was seventeen or so, slight, with long light-brown hair she kept tucking behind one ear, and a white tank top with a little gold cross on a chain, and she was always a step behind him and a little to the left, the way a girl walks behind a boy she is with in a crowd. When he stood at the front of the youth room on Wednesday nights she stood by the wall. When he took the kids bowling she was there in the lane behind him, fixing the strap of her top. In the pictures the kids posted from youth camp at Lake Hartwell, there she was on the dock beside him in every one, and when they showed him the pictures on their phones, he looked and looked and saw the dock, and himself, and the water.

Who's she? the kids asked him, the first few times.

Who?

After a while they stopped asking. Kids get used to things. The parents took longer, and some of them never did, but at first, that spring, people were mostly kind about it, the way a town is kind about a thing it cannot explain. Destiny Bowen, who was nineteen and worked the counter at the Grounds on Sunday mornings, would pour his black coffee and then pour a second one with cream and sugar and set them both up on the counter.

One for you, she said, *and one for your friend.*

The first time he laughed and said he didn't have a friend. After that he carried both cups back to his office and set the second one on the corner of his desk, where it went cold, and poured it out in the bathroom sink at noon. The waitress at the Waffle House on Clemson Boulevard set out two waters. The ladies who did the Wednesday supper put an extra roll on his plate. *For your girl,* they said, as if he had a girl, and he said thank you.

II. Kayleigh

Cane Creek · 2006

He knew who she was. He had known from the first week. He had not told anyone, because there was no way to say it that a person would believe.

The summer he was eighteen, the two boys he loved most in the world were Josh Clary and Tanner Black. They had been in the same Sunday school class at Cane Creek First Baptist since they were four, and the two of them had signed their pledge cards the same night he did, and they were so close that the youth pastor called them the Twins, though they did not look alike at all. They prayed together before ball games. They went to See You at the Pole together every September and stood at the flagpole at the high school holding hands with their eyes shut. Every first Sunday they walked down the aisle side by side when the communion was passed, and everybody in Cane Creek knew it. Caleb was always the third one, a step behind them.

That spring he made a MySpace page for a girl named Kayleigh.

He never could say afterward exactly why. He would sit in his car and try to say it to himself, and it always came out sounding like something smaller than what it had been. He wanted to see if the thing between them would break. He took the pictures off the page of a girl in Knoxville he did not know, a girl with long light-brown hair and a little gold cross who had posted them for her own friends, and he made Kayleigh seventeen, from Greenville, saved, and lonely. Kayleigh wrote to Josh. Josh, who had never had a girl write to him in his life, wrote back. In July, the week after church camp at Lake Hartwell, Kayleigh posted a picture of herself in a white tank top fixing the strap, and under it, on Josh's page, where anybody could see it, she wrote: *last night at the lake was everything. dont tell T.*

Tanner saw it. Josh swore up and down he had never met any girl at the lake. He swore it on the Bible in Tanner's truck. He cried. *Don't do me like this, man. I never did anything.* And Tanner said what he had seen he had seen. On the first Sunday in August, when the communion came,

Tanner got up out of the pew and walked down the side aisle by himself, and when he had taken it he did not go back to the pew where Josh was sitting. Everybody in Cane Creek saw that, too.

Caleb had sat three rows behind them and watched the back of Josh Clary's neck go red. He went home and lay on his bed until it was dark. Then he got up and logged in as Kayleigh one last time and wrote to Tanner. *Josh never did anything. I'm not real. I made this up to see if you would stand by him. Please go back.* He deleted the page that night. He never told them who Kayleigh had been.

The Twins made it up. They stood at the pole that September. But Tanner was never easy with Josh again the way he had been, and when Josh's mother called the sheriff's office about the fake page, there was not anything the deputy could do.

After that there were five years Caleb did not talk about. He went to Clemson for a year and left. He drove a forklift at a warehouse in Greenville and took the pills a man at the warehouse sold him for his back, and then took them for other reasons, and then for no reason at all. He lived in a lot of places that were not good places, and he was in a kind of hell for those years, and he knew it was a hell, and he knew, the way you know where a sound is coming from in the dark, that he had made it. Then he was not in it anymore. He went home to his grandmother in Cane Creek and got clean on her couch and went back to church. He went to a Bible college in Greenville. He told Pastor Ruth Ann Dobbins all of it, Kayleigh too, the morning she interviewed him for the job at Open Field, sitting in her office in what had been the Walmart's manager's office, with the one-way window looking out over the sanctuary floor. She hired him anyway.

The girl behind him had long light-brown hair and a little gold cross. When people described her to him he did not have to ask what she looked like.

III. The Givers

Open Field Church · June

THE TROUBLE CAME FROM INSIDE THE STAFF.

There were nine pastors on staff at Open Field, and by June the others had stopped being kind. Trent Gaines, who led worship, said the girl had been seen getting into Caleb's car at the Waffle House. Missy Hollifield, who ran the children's wing, said a mother had pulled her daughter out of the youth group because of the pictures from camp. Bradley Moon, the executive pastor, who had come from a big church in Atlanta and knew how these things went, said what all of them were thinking. There was a pastor in Greenville who had been in the papers. There were pastors all over the country in the papers. If it came out that the youth pastor at Open Field went around with a teenage girl in a tank top, it would not matter what anybody said afterward. It would be all of them. It would be the church.

They went first to Don Rampey, who owned the Ford dealership on Clemson Boulevard and had given the money to buy the building. They sat in his office at the dealership with the shades down.

Get him off the property, Don. For all our sakes.

Mr. Rampey heard them out. Then he said, *Is Ruth Ann not at the church?*

She's there.

Well, then. She'll know.

They went to Miss Bev Crenshaw, who had owned a uniform company in Belton for forty years and had paid for the whole Lawn and Garden wing out of her own pocket, and who was the one person at Open Field that Pastor Ruth Ann sometimes asked for advice. Miss Bev gave them iced tea on her porch and listened, and at the end of it she said the same thing Don had.

Have y'all asked Ruth Ann?

They had not. They did not want to. Ruth Ann had hired him herself, and she had a way of looking at you when you brought her something about somebody else that made you wish you had not brought it.

So they went to the police.

IV. The Porch Light

Cane Creek · a night in July

Lamar Gentry had been chief of police in Cane Creek for nineteen years, which meant he had three officers and a Crown Victoria and knew everybody in town and what their granddaddies had done in the mill. Caleb lived in Cane Creek, in the right-hand half of a brick duplex on Mill Street, so it was Lamar the three pastors came to, with their phones full of pictures, and laid them out on his desk one at a time.

We don't know how old she is, Bradley Moon said. *That's the thing. We think she could be a minor.*

The chief looked at the pictures a long time. He knew Caleb Pruitt. He had known his grandmother since before the mill shut. He had also been a policeman long enough to know that you never did know.

Y'all go on home, he said. *I'll see about it.*

He went that night after dark, with two of his officers. He put one at the back of the duplex by the clotheslines and one at the corner of Mill Street, and he stood himself in the front yard, on the grass, facing the door, and knocked on the porch post with his flashlight.

Caleb came out under the porch light in his socks. He stood on the top step, facing the chief, and the chief saw her plain as day: a girl in a white top, standing in the doorway right behind him, with one hand up tucking her hair behind her ear. The chief saw the little gold cross catch the light.

Evening, Chief.

Caleb saw it was Lamar Gentry, and saw the officer at the corner, and he went back inside and sat down on his couch the way you sit down when something you have expected for a long time has come. The chief came in behind him without being asked. There was nobody in the front room but Caleb. The chief went through the kitchen. He opened the bathroom door and pulled back the shower curtain. He looked in the bedroom closet and got down on one knee with his flashlight and looked under the bed. He came back out.

Son, where's the girl?

I don't see any girl, Chief.

I just now saw her. She was standing right behind you.

I don't see her.

The chief stood a minute in the middle of the room with his hat in his hand. *Step back out on the porch for me a second.*

Caleb went out and stood on the top step facing the yard. The chief went down the steps and turned around on the grass, and there she was again, in the doorway at Caleb's shoulder, fixing her strap. The chief went back up the steps fast and into the house past him, and Caleb came in and sat on the couch, and the room was empty. The chief looked in the closets again. He looked behind the shower curtain again. He looked in the kitchen pantry, which was too small to hold a cat.

Son, I am asking you. Where is she.

Chief, Caleb said, *that's what everybody says. Everybody says there's a girl with me everywhere I go. I have never once seen her.*

Lamar Gentry's grandmother had lived in a mill house two streets over until she was ninety-four, and she had told him once about a woman in a blue dress who sat on the end of her bed every night the winter after her husband died, and that you did not speak to such things and they did not mean you any harm, mostly. He had not thought about it in forty years.

Do me one more favor. Go out there one more time.

Caleb went out. The chief went down and turned in the grass. The girl was in the doorway behind Caleb with her hand at her hair, under the yellow porch light, with the moths going around it. She did not look at the chief. She was looking at the back of Caleb's neck. And when the chief went up the steps this time he went slowly, watching her the whole way, and at the top step he could not have said the moment she was not there. There was the doorframe and the porch light and the moths, and Caleb going past him into the house.

The chief stood in the front room and put his hat back on.

Well, he said. *That's not anybody I can arrest.*

He was quiet a while. Then he said, *Son, you know with that thing following you around, nobody in this county is going to have you to Sunday dinner. Not after people start talking. So you'll eat at my house. Sundays after church, and any other day you want. Mary Lynn won't mind. She cooks for six anyhow.*

He told the officers to go home, and got in the Crown Victoria and went home himself.

V. The Chief's Boy

Open Field Church · August

It got around, because things do. By the first of August the whole staff knew that Lamar Gentry had gone out to Mill Street to run Caleb Pruitt off and had come home and set a place for him at his own table, and that Caleb ate there every Sunday now, pot roast and rice and gravy, and that Mary Lynn Gentry set two places for him and did not say a word about it.

The staff took it hard. They had gone to the law and the law had gone over to him.

Trent Gaines said it first, at the coffee machine in the staff break room, which had been the Walmart's employee break room and still had the safety poster on the wall. *How's the chief's boy this morning?* In the staff meeting Bradley Moon made a joke about whose son Caleb really was, and what his mama had been up to, and two of them laughed. Missy Hollifield did not laugh, but she did not say anything either. It went on for a week. They said it in the hallway behind the stage and in the group text he was on. *Chief's bastard.* They said he had a girl in his house and a cop in his pocket.

Nobody at Open Field had ever heard Caleb Pruitt raise his voice. In the staff meeting on the second Tuesday of August, when Bradley Moon said something about the chief's boy getting his own reserved parking, Caleb stood up.

He told them they were frauds. He said every one of them was sleeping with somebody, or wanted to, or had, and he named names, people in the church, people they had been seen with, a woman at the Atlanta church Bradley had come from. He said it all in a level voice and he did not stop. He did not know where any of it came from. He had never seen any of it with his own eyes. It came up out of him from somewhere a long way

down, as if it had been there waiting, and it was the most he had said in a staff meeting in seven months.

Then he sat down. Nobody said anything for a while.

That afternoon the three of them went up the stairs to Pastor Ruth Ann's office.

VI. The Cymbal

The manager's office · the same day

Ruth Ann Dobbins was fifty-eight. She had started Open Field with her husband Wade in 1996 in a storefront in Belton with forty folding chairs, and when Wade died of a heart attack on the riding mower in 2010 she had kept on. She was raised Free Will Baptist in Honea Path, in a white church with a piano and no drums where the women did not preach, and her grandmother, who had been a schoolteacher, had read to her out of an American Standard Bible with a cracked black cover that she still kept on her desk. When she was nineteen, with a baby and no husband, she had danced six years at a club off I-85 near the Georgia line to keep the lights on, and she had told that from the pulpit exactly once, on the first Sunday the church met, and never again, and never needed to. She preached short. Most Sundays she let Wade's younger brother preach and sat on the front row. What she mostly did was pray with people in this office, one at a time, for as long as it took.

She heard the three of them out. Then she picked up the phone and asked Caleb to come up.

He came and stood just inside the door. Destiny had brought up two coffees for him at the staff meeting, and he still had the second one in his hand, cold, because he had not known where to put it down.

Caleb, they say you said these things to them this morning. Is that so?

Yes ma'am. All of it.

Why did you?

Because of what they've been saying to me.

She turned to the others. *And why have y'all been saying it to him?*

Because of the girl, Bradley said. *Ruth Ann, we've all seen her. You've seen her.*

She was quiet a while. Then she said to Caleb, very gently, as if they were the only two in the room:

They said what they said because of what they saw with their eyes. You know what they saw. I've seen it too. She let that sit. *What did you see, son, when you said what you said to them?*

He did not answer.

You sat in that chair a year ago in January and told me something about a girl named Kayleigh. You remember that.

Yes ma'am.

That girl behind you is what that has come to. I don't know how it works and I don't need to. You know it better than I do. You made something up about a boy you loved and said it where everybody could hear it, and it never did go back in. She looked at him over her glasses. *And now you have done it again. You stood up in that room and said a pile of things you never saw. You want to make another one?*

The three pastors by the window did not know what she was talking about, and she did not tell them. She told them they could go. When they had gone she got up and went to the bookshelf behind her desk.

On the bottom shelf was a crash cymbal. It had come off the drum kit in the sanctuary after Easter, when the drummer hit it wrong in the last chorus and it split, a crack an inch and a half long running in from the rim. The drummer had put it in the dumpster behind the loading dock, and Ruth Ann had gone out and taken it back out of the dumpster in her church shoes, and nobody knew why. She set it on the desk between them. She took off her wedding ring and tapped the cymbal with it, near the edge. Where there should have been a long bright ring that filled the room, there was a little dead click, like somebody setting down a fork.

That's you from now on, she said. *They say something to you, you be this. Don't you answer them back one word. Not in the meeting, not in the text, not in your own head on the drive home. A word said hard gets a word back, and the word back gets a hand, and it does not stop. If you can be this, it stops with you.*

She opened her grandmother's Bible and read it to him, the way her grandmother had read it to her, slow:

> *A soft answer turneth away wrath; But a grievous word stirreth up anger.*
>
> *— Proverbs 15:1*
>
> *For lack of wood the fire goeth out; And where there is no whisperer, contention ceaseth.*
>
> *— Proverbs 26:20*

Caleb set the cold coffee down on the corner of her desk, beside the cymbal. Then he sat down in the chair across from her, the same chair, and put his face in his hands. Ruth Ann did not say anything else. She sat with him, the way she sat with everybody.

VII. Number One

Wednesday nights · that fall

HE DID WHAT SHE TOLD HIM.

It was harder than the pills. Trent Gaines said *chief's boy* at the coffee machine the next morning, out of habit, and Caleb felt the whole sentence come up in him, ready, the way a dog comes up off a porch, and he let it lie down again. He did it the next day and the day after that. In the group text he did not answer. In his car on the way home, when the old talk started up in his head, he let that lie down too. He thought of the little dead click of the cymbal. There was a verse in the Psalms he found on his own that month in the old American Standard, and he wrote it on an index card and kept it on the dash of his car, and read it at red lights:

> *I said, I will take heed to my ways, That I sin not with my tongue: I will keep my mouth with a bridle, While the wicked is before me. I was dumb with silence, I held my peace, even from good; And my sorrow was stirred.*
>
> *— Psalm 39:1–2*

And something happened, though he never would claim it. It happened slowly through September, and all at once one morning in October, at the light by the Ford dealership, with the rain coming down. He noticed there was nothing in him waiting to answer anybody. He looked for it, the way you feel with your tongue for a tooth that has been aching, and it was gone. There was a quiet in him like the quiet in the big building on a Monday, when the floor has been mopped and the chairs are stacked and the long lights hum. He sat through two greens with people honking behind him.

The staff got tired of saying things to someone who did not say anything back. By Thanksgiving they had mostly stopped. Bradley Moon took a job at a church in Nashville in the spring.

• • •

Wednesday nights at Open Field there was a family supper in the old garden center before the youth service: five dollars a plate, two dollars for kids, free for anybody who said they could not pay and no questions asked. Miss Bev Crenshaw sat at a card table by the doors with a cash box and a roll of pink tickets, the kind they sell at a county fair, and tore you one off the roll, and you gave it to the ladies at the steam table for your plate.

On the second Wednesday in November, the kids who were out in the parking lot before supper say they saw Caleb Pruitt standing in the air.

They tell it plain, the ones who were there. It was getting dark. He was not on a ladder and he was not on the roof. He was standing up in the air over the front doors, about as high as the place on the wall where the old Walmart letters had been, with his hands in his jacket pockets, as if he were reading them. A girl named Hannah Tate dropped her phone on the asphalt and cracked the screen. Nobody thought to take a picture. Then he came down, the way you come down a flight of stairs, and went in through the automatic doors, and he was the first one at Miss Bev's card table, before the families, before the kids came running in from the lot.

Miss Bev tore him off ticket number one.

After that, whoever had the cash box on Wednesday nights saved him the first ticket on the roll, and nobody remembers who started it. If he was late they kept it for him under the edge of the cash box. He never asked for it. He always paid his five dollars.

People still saw the girl, after that, a step behind him and a little to the left. They said she looked different, though nobody could say how. She did not fix her strap anymore, or tuck her hair. She stood there.

Destiny Bowen still poured two coffees on Sunday mornings, his black, the other with cream and sugar. He still carried them both back to his office. He set the second one on the corner of the desk, where the cymbal used to be before Ruth Ann gave it to him to keep, and around noon, when it was cold, he took it down the hall to the bathroom and poured it out in the sink, and rinsed the cup, and set it upside down on a paper towel to dry.

Background

The verses

> *Do not speak harshly to anybody; those who are spoken to will answer thee in the same way. Angry speech is painful, blows for blows will touch thee.*
>
> Dhammapada 133, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If, like a shattered metal plate (gong), thou utter not, then thou hast reached Nirvana; contention is not known to thee.*
>
> Dhammapada 134, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, from the day the monk Kuṇḍadhāna is ordained, the form of a woman follows him everywhere. Everyone sees her except him, and villagers on his alms round give one portion "for you" and another "for our female friend." In a former life, in the time of an earlier Buddha, he had been a deity who took a woman's form to make one of two inseparable monks look unchaste, so that the other refused to keep the Observance Day with him; the deity confessed, the monks were reconciled but never as close, and the deity went to hell. Now the monks ask the great lay supporters Anāthapiṇḍika and Visākhā to expel Kuṇḍadhāna; both say the Teacher will know. The monks go to King Pasenadi, who surrounds the monk's cell, sees the woman only when the monk stands outside, searches the room three times, decides she is an apparition, and invites the monk to eat at the palace. The jealous monks

call Kuṇḍadhāna the king's bastard; he, who has never answered anyone, calls them corrupt and unchaste. The Buddha asks both sides why they spoke: the monks spoke from what they saw, but what had he seen? He tells the old deed and bids him be silent as a gong broken at the rim. Kuṇḍadhāna becomes an arahant, flies up into the air, and takes the first meal ticket, and he is later named foremost among those who receive meal tickets. Read the full commentary story.

Anderson County, South Carolina

Upstate South Carolina, 2015

By the 2000s large evangelical congregations were outgrowing their buildings and moving into vacant commercial property, strip malls and empty big-box stores among it, as the *Wall Street Journal* reported in 2006. Many were nondenominational megachurches, usually defined as Protestant churches with two thousand or more people in weekly attendance. Anderson, on I-85 about halfway between Atlanta and Charlotte, was called the Electric City after a hydroelectric plant on the Rocky River began sending power there in 1895, and cotton mills grew up from the 1870s in Anderson, Pelzer, Belton, Honea Path and Williamston. By 1920 Anderson County had nineteen textile mills; by the 1990s foreign competition had closed many of them, leaving the mill villages behind.

Caleb's ring belongs to the evangelical purity movement of the 1990s. The Southern Baptist campaign True Love Waits asked teenagers to sign cards pledging abstinence until marriage; on July 29, 1994, an estimated 200,000 signed cards were staked into the lawn of the National Mall, according to NPR. Many pledgers wore a ring as a sign of the promise. By 2006, when Kayleigh's page went up, MySpace was the most visited website in the United States.

After the story of the Elder Kuṇḍadhāna from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 133–134). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.5

A to Izzard

Time cuts down all
Both great and small.
— The New-England Primer (Boston, 1727)

So I have heard it told, at the east end of Marlow common.

I. The Nooning

Marlow, Hampshire County, Massachusetts · Fast Day, April 1805

The Governor's proclamation had been read from the pulpit, and it said what it said every spring: a day of public fasting, humiliation and prayer, with servile labor and recreation laid by. In Marlow that meant two sermons with an hour between them and nothing to eat until the sun was behind West Hill.

The men spent the hour by the horse block, talking low. The women went where the women of Marlow had always gone at the nooning, forty rods down the hill to the kitchen of Marm Bascom, who kept the dame school.

She was seventy-eight and had not climbed to the meetinghouse in four winters. She sat at the end of the settle with her bad hip to the fire. For fifty-one years she had taken the town's children at three years old, at fourpence ha'penny a week, and kept them until they could read a chapter and the girls could hem. The boys went on to the master. The girls went home, since Marlow had never paid a master to teach girls. So every woman in that kitchen who had been born in the town had learned her letters on that floor, first off the horn-book on its string and then out of the Primer, and any of them could have put a finger on the place at the crown of her head where Marm's thimble used to come down.

They came in the way they sat in meeting, by age. The widows had the settle and the two chairs. The wives of middle years stood along the dresser and took turns at the hearth, shoveling fresh coals into their foot stoves. The young wives stood behind them. The girls stood along the wall by the door, under the samplers.

Madam Field came in last. She was Squire Field's wife. She had given the meetinghouse its bell and the minister half his books, and there was hardly a husband in the parish who had not at some time told his wife to go and ask Madam Field. All through the morning sermon something had been working at her. Mr. Hale had preached on fasting. Five or six times he had asked the congregation to what end they afflicted themselves, and each time he had answered for them. She wanted to hear them answer for themselves.

So she asked, and she began with the settle.

For my soul, Mercy, said the Widow Smead, who was eighty-one. *What else is there left to fast for? I should like to be let in.* The other widows nodded. To be let in, and to find their own people there.

Along the dresser nobody spoke. Then Abigail Graves, whose husband carried the key of the meal chest in his own waistcoat, said, *To be out from under Mr. Graves's hand. I don't say how. I leave the how to Providence.* There was a laugh, and it stopped quickly, and two or three of the others said that they had prayed about the same, give or take the name.

The young wives looked at their shoes. *A child,* said Thankful Cook, who had been married a year in March. *Soon, if it please God. Before his mother says anything more about it.*

The girls by the door were fourteen and sixteen and nineteen. They pushed Dolly Smead to the front. *Husbands, ma'am,* she said, and someone behind her said, *While we're young and can pick.*

Madam Field did not laugh at any of it. She turned to the fire and told it all over to Marm Bascom, who was a little deaf and had not caught the half. She told it in order, oldest to youngest, as a child says a lesson. The old ones fasted for heaven. The wives fasted to be loosed from their husbands. The brides fasted for children, and the girls for husbands.

II. The Drove

The Bay Road · the same hour

Marm Bascom did not answer, because there was a noise in the road, and she had turned to the window.

It was a drove from the river towns, sixty or seventy fat oxen bound for the market at Little Cambridge. They had stood in the stall since November eating corn and English hay. The drover ought to have lain by for the Fast, and every woman at the window knew it. A man rode ahead on a gray horse. The drover walked behind with a hickory stick, and two boys with switches walked the flanks. The cattle filled the road from bank to bank, red and brindle, and steam rose off their backs.

Watch how he does it, Marm said. She had watched droves from that window for fifty years. *He doesn't strike. He holds the stick out where the near ox can see it, and the ox moves off from it, and the rest go because that one goes. Hurry a fat beast and he walks his tallow off, and the tallow is what they pay for. He'll have them eight or nine days on the road, with hay every night, and they'll go in at the gate as sleek as they left the stall.*

One of the boys was no bigger than her oldest scholars. He laid his switch against the hock of a steer that had stopped to look at the meetinghouse, and the steer went on.

She turned back from the window when the last of them had passed.

There are four that carry the stick, she said. *Being born starts you out of the yard. Age has you from there. Sickness takes you over from age, and death walks behind for the last mile and puts up the bars. None of them hurries you. You have every one of you been on the road since before I had you, and I have had you all.*

She looked down the room the way she used to look down a bench.

I heard what you fasted for. A man. A cradle. A lighter yoke. Good pasture at the far end, Hannah Smead, with all your people standing in it. Each of you asked for more road. I didn't hear one ask how a creature gets out of the drove.

Nobody answered her. Out on the Bay Road the sound of the cattle was going away east.

III. Izzard

The kitchen · before the second bell

THEN SHE DID WHAT SHE HAD DONE WITH ALL OF THEM WHEN they were small. She took the Primer down from the shelf over the settle. It was her own, the one she had learned from in her mother's kitchen, and it had lost its boards long ago and was sewn into a piece of bed ticking.

Say T, she said, and rapped the arm of the settle with her thimble.

The girls and the young wives had it out before they could think. *Young Timothy learnt sin to fly.* Under them, slower, came the widows and the oldest of the wives, saying something else.

There, said Marm. *You hear that. When I had kept school a few years a new book came up from Boston. Somebody had gone through the letters and mended them. He took Time out at T and put in a good boy. But he couldn't take him off the road.*

She did not open the book. She said the old letters as she had learned them, and the widows said them with her.

> *As runs the Glass*
> *Mans life doth pass.*
>
> *Time cuts down all*
> *Both great and small.*
>
> *Xerxes the great did die,*
> *And so must you & I.*
>
> *Youth forward slips*
> *Death soonest nips.*
>
> — *The New-England Primer (Boston, 1727), letters G, T, X and Y*

Then comes Zaccheus up his tree, and that's izzard, and the book is done, she said. *I never yet had a scholar get to izzard who didn't ask to turn back to A and have the pictures over again.*

The bell began on the hill. The women took up their foot stoves and went out as they had come in, by age, the widows first. Madam Field stayed a moment by the settle.

You asked every one of them, Mercy Field, said Marm. *You never said what you came fasting for yourself.*

I had it when I came down the hill, said Madam Field. *I find I've mislaid it.*

Leave it lie, said Marm.

• • •

They say in Marlow that a good many of the women kept the Fast differently after that year. Nobody could tell how, because it looked the same from the men's side of the house. Abigail Graves went on praying about Mr. Graves. But when the Widow Smead lay dying the next winter and Mr. Hale asked her what she looked for, she said that she had left off looking for anything in particular, and he wrote in his book that she seemed easy.

The fast was broken at sundown. The road froze that night with the drove still printed in it, bank to bank, every hoof pointing east. In the morning the youngest Cook child, who was three, stepped over the prints with her fourpence ha'penny tied in the corner of a handkerchief. She sat down on the kitchen floor, and Marm Bascom put the horn-book in her hand and set her finger on the first letter.

Background

The verse

> *As a cowherd with his staff drives his cows into the stable, so do Age and Death drive the life of men.*
>
> Dhammapada 135, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred women of Sāvatthī keep the Observance Day and go to the monastery. The great laywoman Visākhā asks each age in turn why they keep it. The oldest want a heavenly reward, the women in middle life want release from the power of their husbands, the young wives want to conceive, and the maid-

ens want husbands while they are still young. She brings the answers to the Buddha in order. He says that birth, old age, sickness and death are like cowherds with staves, each handing living beings on to the next, and that even so nobody wishes for an end of rebirth; rebirth is all they desire. Read the full commentary story, or about Visākhā.

Hampshire County, Massachusetts

A Massachusetts hill town, 1805

Marlow and its people are invented. The annual Fast Day was real: each spring the governor of Massachusetts proclaimed a day of public fasting, humiliation and prayer, kept with public worship and abstinence from food. Massachusetts kept the holiday until 1894. Small children, and girls above all, learned to read from a neighborhood woman in a dame school. Sylvester Judd's *History of Hadley* records that girls in the valley towns "learned to read and sew of school dames," and that Northampton did not admit girls to its town schools until 1802. The same book describes the valley farmers who stall-fed oxen through the winter and drove them to market near Boston. The cattle market there, begun in 1775, stood in the part of Cambridge called Little Cambridge, which became the town of Brighton in 1807. "Fourpence ha'penny" was the New England name for the Spanish half-real, a small silver coin that passed everywhere. "Izzard" is an old name for the letter Z.

The New England Primer taught generations of children their letters through a rhymed alphabet with a small woodcut for each couplet. The couplets in the story are from the oldest surviving edition, printed in Boston in 1727 and reprinted in Paul Leicester Ford's *The New-England Primer: A History of Its Origin and Development* (1897). Ford shows that between about 1740 and 1760 the worldlier rhymes were rewritten to be more pious. In an edition of 1777, T is "Young Timothy / Learnt sin to fly," X is "Xerxes did die, / And so must I," and Y is "While youth do chear / Death may be near." A woman schooled in the 1730s and her granddaughters would have known different alphabets.

After the story of Visākhā and the women keeping the Observance Day from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 135). The original. Verses from *The New-England Primer* (Boston, 1727). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

10.6

Four Hundredweight

…here it is the soul itself that is tearing itself in pieces.
— St. Teresa of Jesus, Life, ch. 32

Thus it was told me, at the landing on Nanjemoy Creek.

I. The Landing

St. Thomas's, Charles County, Maryland · November 1717

The Jesuits' house stood on the high ground where Port Tobacco River runs into the Potomac, and the path down to their landing was steep enough that a man carrying oars took it sideways. Peter Cole took it sideways every morning of his life. He was about forty. He belonged to the Jesuits, as the boat did and the cattle did, and he had rowed their priests up and down the rivers of Charles County since he was fourteen, to every house on the Neck where there was a room with an altar in it. He could find a creek mouth in the dark by the smell of it. The men who worked with him said he saw further than other people, and not only on the water.

Matthew Spurling carried the other pair of oars. He was seventeen and had come out of Bristol in the spring, bound for five years to pay his passage, and the Jesuits had bought his time off the ship at Annapolis. He was a Protestant and had been told he would not be made anything else, and nobody had tried. He was still afraid of the river.

It was the grey before sunrise, and the frost was on the path. Father Langworth was to be rowed down to Nanjemoy to say Mass in a house there and come back by dark. Halfway down the hill, where the trees open and the whole river lies below, Peter stopped. Matthew nearly walked into him. Peter stood with the oars on his shoulder and looked

down the Port Tobacco to the Potomac and along the Potomac as far as it went, toward the Virginia shore, slowly, the whole length of it. Then he smiled.

Matthew had not seen him smile in seven months.

What is it?

Not here, Peter said. *Ask me tonight in the shop, in front of Brother Hollis.*

II. The Shop

That evening

Brother John Hollis was a Jesuit who would never be a priest. He had come out from England in 1693 as a lay brother, which meant he took the vows and kept them and was not ordained, and he did the work. He was a joiner. He had made most of the altars on the Neck, and all of the boxes they folded into, so that a priest could close up a chapel in a minute and leave a room that looked like a parlor. He was nearly seventy. He talked less than anyone at St. Thomas's, which was saying something, and men went to his shop in the evenings with things they would not take to a priest.

When the boat was in and Father Langworth had gone up to the house, Peter and Matthew came to the shop. Brother Hollis was planing a cherry board by a rushlight. Matthew asked. Peter sat on the sawhorse.

When we came down this morning, Peter said, *there was a great snake lying in the river. His head was at the point under the house, and his body went down the Potomac past Cedar Point, farther than I could see. Thicker than a hogshead. And he was all on fire. The fire started at his head and ran to the end of him and started at the end and ran back up, and more fire came out of his sides and fell on his back. The river was not on fire, only him. I smiled because I have heard that there are such things, and I had never seen one.*

Matthew looked from one to the other. Peter was not a man who joked, and neither was the brother.

Brother Hollis set down the plane.

You have eyes, Peter, he said, *and you use them.* He brushed the shavings off the board with the side of his hand. *I have seen him too. The morning I*

took my last vows, in August, at the five o'clock Mass, I came out of the chapel and he was lying in the river just as you say. I have seen him most mornings since. I did not speak of it. Who would believe it of an old joiner? And the ones who did not believe it would have laughed at it, and it is not good for a man to laugh at a thing like that. I kept quiet for their sake. Now there are two of us.

He looked at Matthew.

You knew him, Peter. He used to sell you fish. It is Kit Lowry.

III. Four Hundredweight

Mr. Thorogood's landing, Nanjemoy · 1715

Mr. Basil Thorogood had three thousand acres on Nanjemoy Creek, and forty people who were his, and a brick house with glazed windows that he had built in the year of the Revolution, when the Protestants took the government and his family had to give up their places in it. He had been a justice of the county then. He was not one now, and would not be again, and he did not seem to mind. He was a short, loud, happy man who could not sit still at a table. He fed everybody. On a Sunday when a priest came, forty and fifty people came up from the creeks to hear Mass at his house and stayed to dinner, Catholics and Protestants both, and the Protestants came back the next time for the dinner.

Since the law of 1704 a priest could not say Mass in any public chapel in Maryland, only in the house of a private family. So the Catholic families built rooms onto their houses. Mr. Thorogood's was the best on the Neck. Brother Hollis had built it for him: a long room off the west end of the house, with its own door to the yard, a plastered ceiling, and an altar of black walnut that folded shut into a press. There was a little window over the altar of colored glass that Mr. Thorogood had sent to London for, and when the sun came through it in the morning it laid red and blue on the floor. The house people swept that room before they swept any other. Mr. Thorogood went into it every morning, priest or no priest, and knelt on the bare floor a quarter of an hour, and came out pleased with the whole world. Of all he owned, it was the thing he loved.

That was the year the new Lord Baltimore swore he was a Protestant and got Maryland back for his family, and every Catholic on the Neck understood that this changed nothing for them. It was also the year the Assembly passed the new law on servants. A runaway servant was to serve up to ten days for every day he had been away, and whoever took him up and brought him before a magistrate was to have four hundred pounds of tobacco from the master.

On a morning in October Mr. Thorogood walked down to his landing before sunrise to meet the boat that was bringing the priest. He had his man Harry with him to carry the lantern. In the tobacco house by the landing, among the hanging leaf, there was a man asleep in the straw, with his legs muddy to the knee and his coat pulled over his head.

Mr. Thorogood was in a good humor. He pointed with his stick.

Look at that, Harry. Somebody's runaway. There's four hundredweight of tobacco lying in my straw.

The man in the straw pulled the coat down off his face and looked at him.

I'll be even with you, he said.

Mr. Thorogood laughed and went down to meet the boat. By the time the priest was ashore the man was gone, and by the time Mass was said Mr. Thorogood had forgotten him.

IV. Seven Times

Nanjemoy · 1715–1716

The man was Kit Lowry. He was not a runaway. He had served out seven years in Prince George's County as a boy and had his freedom dues, a hat and a suit of clothes, two hoes and an axe, and nothing else. He had married a woman who had also served her time, and they had two children and a cabin on rented ground at the head of the creek. He fished. He took a hog out of the woods now and then that was not his, and he had been out after one that night and had lain down in the nearest dry place, and he had been priced in his sleep like a calf.

Ten days later Mr. Thorogood's tobacco house by the landing burned with the whole crop hanging in it.

On the Neck they say it was seven times. Seven times he burned the tobacco, and seven times he went into the woods where Mr. Thorogood's cattle ranged and cut the hamstrings of a steer, and seven times he set fire to the house. Brother Hollis said that seven was a good number for a story, and that he himself had counted three tobacco houses, the kitchen, the dairy, the barn with the corn in it, and eleven head of cattle lying in the woods with their legs cut, which the house people had to finish with an axe. Mr. Thorogood did not know who did it. He did not think of the man in the straw. He rebuilt each thing as it went, and when people came to Mass he fed them as before, and he did not complain, and he did not lose his good humor, and that was the worst of it for Kit Lowry. A man can be revenged on a man who is unhappy.

So Kit went to the landing on a Saturday evening when Harry was down there alone, and he gave him a piece of fish and some of a bottle, and asked him what his master thought most of in the world.

The mass room, said Harry. *It isn't close. He thinks more of that room than he does of his wife.*

In January the priest went upriver for a fortnight, and Kit Lowry broke the glass cruets for the wine and water, and the candlesticks, and the colored window, and he poured lamp oil on the walnut and set the mass room alight.

Mr. Thorogood was down at the landing when they shouted. He ran. By the time he got around the end of the house the room was gone. The roof had come in on the altar. The brick of the house wall stood black, with the shape of the room printed on it in soot.

He stood and looked at it. The people who had run up from the quarter and the kitchen stood around him and waited for him to fall down. And Mr. Thorogood crooked his left arm against his chest and struck the inside of the elbow with the flat of his right hand, hard, as loud as a pistol, three times, the way a man applauds a horse that has won.

Master, said Harry. *Master, that was your room.*

I know it, Mr. Thorogood said. *I have had all these years to put what God gave me into things for Him, and every time it burns I get to do it again. I am clapping because I am going to build that room twice.*

V. The Octave

Nanjemoy · Easter 1717

Brother Hollis built it twice. It took him and two men of the house from February to Lent. The walnut was harder to find the second time and the glass came from London again at twice the price, and Mr. Thorogood paid it. At Easter the priest blessed the new room, and Mr. Thorogood kept the octave. For eight days Mass was said in the room every morning and the whole Neck ate at his house every noon: shad from the creek, and hams, and hominy, and the first greens. People camped in the yard. Protestants came too, for the dinner, and stood at the back of the mass room in their hats out of curiosity.

Kit Lowry came every day. He had a butcher's knife pushed down inside his breeches against his hip. He had understood by now that nothing he could burn would touch the man, and that only one thing was left. For seven days he stood in the yard and in the back of the room, and ate at the long tables, and waited, and Mr. Thorogood was never alone for a breath. People had their hands on him from morning to night.

On the eighth morning, before the priest began, Mr. Thorogood stood up in front of the altar with his hat in his hands.

Father, he said, *you know I have had some losses. Seven times a man has burned my tobacco, and seven times he has hamstrung my cattle, and seven times he has burned my house, and I am sure it was the same man who burned this room. I do not know his name. I ask you to offer this Mass for him. Whatever good there is in this room and in this week, I want him to have the first of it.*

The priest looked at him a while and then bowed his head, and said the Mass for that intention. Brother Hollis was kneeling at the side wall, and he said that in all his years he never heard a room so quiet.

Kit Lowry stood at the back with the knife against his hip. He thought, I have done all that to him, and he gives me the first of his Mass. He is a bigger man than I am by the whole of it. And he thought too, being Kit, that if a man so forgiving ever found him out and he had not asked first, the sheriff would not be so forgiving. When the Mass was over he went up the room through the people and knelt down on the new boards in front of Mr. Thorogood.

Pardon me, master.

For what, friend?

All of it. I did it all.

Mr. Thorogood did not raise his voice. He asked him about each thing, one by one, in front of everyone. *The tobacco house at the landing? The steers in the Long Swamp? The kitchen? The room?* And Kit said yes to every one.

But I never saw you in my life, Mr. Thorogood said. *What did I do to you?*

You priced me, Kit said. *In your tobacco house, at the landing. You said there was four hundredweight lying in your straw.*

Mr. Thorogood remembered it then. Everyone in the room saw him remember it. His face went red to the hair, and he knelt down on the boards himself, so that they were two men on their knees in front of the altar.

I did say that, he said. *I said it for a joke and it was a cruel thing to say. Pardon me for it.* And then: *Get up, friend. I pardon you. Go your way.*

Kit did not get up. *If you pardon me, let me serve you. Me and my wife and my two children. Bind us to you. We'll work out the cost of what I burned if it takes my whole life.*

Mr. Thorogood shook his head.

Friend, you did all that over one word of mine. If you were in my house, we would neither of us ever be easy. I have no need of you in my house. I pardon you freely, and there is nothing to work off. Go your way.

Kit went his way. In July he took his canoe out on the Potomac after rock with a storm coming up from Virginia, and he did not come back. They found the canoe at Cedar Point. They never found him.

VI. The Fire Inside

The shop at St. Thomas's · November 1717

The rushlight had burned down to the clip. Brother Hollis lit another from it.

He was forgiven, said Matthew. *Mr. Thorogood forgave him. The priest said a Mass for him.*

He was, said the brother. *And he did all of that. Both things.* He took down a small worn book from the shelf over the bench, the life of the holy mother Teresa that Father Langworth had brought him from England, and found the place without looking long. Teresa, who saw the place made ready for her own sins, and was let out again.

> *If I said that the soul is continually being torn from the body, it would be nothing, for that implies the destruction of life by the hands of another but here it is the soul itself that is tearing itself in pieces. I cannot describe that inward fire or that despair, surpassing all torments and all pain. I did not see who it was that tormented me, but I felt myself on fire, and torn to pieces, as it seemed to me; and, I repeat it, this inward fire and despair are the greatest torments of all.*
>
> *— St. Teresa of Jesus, Life, ch. 32*

Nobody is burning Kit Lowry, Brother Hollis said. *Mr. Thorogood is not. God is not. Kit did not know what he was doing while he did it. He knows now. It is his own fire.*

Peter had not said anything since he told what he saw. He was looking at the board on the bench, which was for a new altar press for a house up the Wicomico, cherry this time, because walnut was getting dear.

He went his way, Peter said.

Matthew looked at him, and then at the brother, and nobody said anything about the forty people at Nanjemoy, or the boat, or the oars.

• • •

On Sunday they rowed Father Langworth down to Nanjemoy. Matthew was in the bow. Mr. Thorogood was at the landing in the cold with his stick, as loud as ever, shouting to them about the tide before they were in hearing. Up at the house the people were already going in at the side door, and the morning sun was low enough to come through the little colored window over the altar and lay red and blue across the new boards, the place where two men had knelt.

The new tobacco house stood by the landing, full of leaf. Its door had no lock on it. Matthew asked Harry why, while they were making the boat fast.

Master won't have one, said Harry. *He says a man who wants to sleep in it can sleep in it.*

Background

The verse

> *A fool does not know when he commits his evil deeds: but the wicked man burns by his own deeds, as if burnt by fire.*
>
> Dhammapada 136, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, coming down from Vulture's Peak with the elder Lakkhaṇa, smiles at something he will explain only before the Buddha: a peta in the shape of a python, many leagues long, with fire running from its head to its tail and back. The Buddha says his disciples have eyes and use them, and that he saw the same being on the night of his awakening but kept silent for the sake of those who would not believe. Then he tells its past. In the time of an earlier Buddha, a generous rich man named Sumaṅgala, walking out at dawn, saw a mud-footed man hiding in a rest-house by the city gate and remarked that he must be a night prowler. The man swore to get even, and burned the rich man's field, maimed his cattle and burned his house, seven times each; then, learning from a servant what his master loved most, he burned the Perfumed Chamber the rich man had built for the Buddha. The rich man clapped for joy at the chance to build it again. When the thief came for seven days with a knife to kill him, the rich man dedicated the merit of his gifts to the unknown arsonist; the thief fell at his feet, the rich man asked his pardon in turn for the careless word, forgave him, and would not take him into his house as a servant. The thief died with the deed unspent. Read the full commentary story.

Charles County, Maryland

Charles County, Maryland, 1715-1717

Maryland was founded as a refuge for English Catholics, but after the Protestant revolution of 1689 the Church of England was established and the old Catholic families were pushed out of office. A 1704 act "to prevent the growth of Popery" forbade priests to exercise their office; Queen Anne then allowed Mass to be said in the chapels of private families, and so Catholic planters built "mass rooms" and "priests' mass-houses" onto their dwellings, served by Jesuits who traveled between them (Catholic Encyclopedia, "Archdiocese of Baltimore", which also lists a Jesuit chapel at Port Tobacco by 1697). In 1715 the colony was returned to the Calvert family only after Charles Calvert, 5th Baron Baltimore, declared himself a Protestant; new oaths followed in 1716 and Catholics lost the vote in 1718. Maryland's labor was by then shifting from indentured servants to enslaved Africans; see Province of Maryland.

The servant law the Assembly passed in 1715 allowed a runaway to be made to serve up to ten days for each day absent (Archives of Maryland, vol. 30, p. 284) and paid four hundred pounds of tobacco to whoever took one up (p. 288); a man servant was owed at the end of his time a hat, a suit of clothes, shoes, two hoes and an axe. Teresa of Ávila's *Life* circulated in English among Catholics from the early 1600s; the passage Brother Hollis reads, her vision of the place prepared for her in hell, is quoted here from David Lewis's translation (1870; 1904 edition). Mr. Thorogood, Kit Lowry, Brother Hollis, Father Langworth, Peter Cole, Matthew Spurling and the house at Nanjemoy are invented.

After the story of the python peta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 136). The original. Quotation from *The Life of St. Teresa of Jesus*, tr. David Lewis (1870; 1904 ed.). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.7

Piedra Negra

> *You can do so very frequently, since the nature of the punishment incurred always corresponds to that of the fault committed.*
> *— Allan Kardec, The Spirits' Book, 399*

Así lo oí yo, in Piedra Negra.

I. The Rock

The south coast of Puerto Rico · 1994

Celestino Vega lived by himself in a wooden house with a zinc roof on the hill above the cane, beside the black rock the barrio was named for. The rock was as big as a bus and older than anybody's story about it. Below it the cane ran down to the sea in every direction, or what was left of the cane, because the central had closed the year before and nobody was cutting it now, and the fields were going back to guinea grass and acacia, and in the dry months they burned.

He had cut cane for the central for thirty-one years. He was sixty-two. He had a machete scar across the back of his left hand and a way of standing with his weight on one hip, from all those years of bending, and he wore a white guayabera every day of his life that was not a working day. Since the central closed, every day was one of those.

On Thursday nights he sat at the white table in the Centro Espiritista Luz y Verdad, down in the town, and went over.

That was how people in Piedra Negra said it. He closed his eyes and put his scarred hand flat on the white cloth beside the glass of water, and his breathing changed, and he went over to where the dead are, and walked among them, and came back and told the people at the table what he had seen. He went to the ones in the light and asked them what they

had done in life to be there. A woman who had given water from her well to anybody who knocked. A man who had raised his dead brother's six children and never once said so. He went down into the dark too, which the other mediums would not do, among the ones who were suffering, the ones who did not yet know they were dead, and asked them what they had done. A man who beat his wife every Saturday for twenty years. A man who sold a neighbor's land out from under him with a forged paper. A woman who had left a baby. And he came back and told it all at the table, plainly, the way you tell what you saw at the market, with names when the dead gave him permission, and people went home and changed how they lived.

He took nothing for it. That was the rule of the centro and of every proper centro since Kardec, that a gift given free is to be given free, and he kept it harder than anybody. People left things anyway. They left flowers on his porch, and coffee in paper bags, and envelopes with ten and twenty dollars in them at the centro for the soup kitchen and the funeral fund and the light bill, and on Thursday nights the line for the white table went out the door and down the steps and along the sidewalk past the panadería.

He had been brought along, as they say, by Doña Monserrate Ayala, the presidenta of Luz y Verdad. She was eighty-four years old. When she was a girl she had embroidered handkerchiefs at home for the American trade by the dozen, by lamplight, for a few cents apiece, and she still had the eyes for it, small and black and missing nothing. She had seen Celestino at fifteen, the year his fits started, when the priest wanted to send him to the hospital in Río Piedras, and she had said, That boy is not sick. That boy has faculties. And she had sat with him at the white table every Thursday for most of fifty years.

She talked less than anybody in the centro. She opened the session with the prayer and closed it with the prayer, and in between she watched, and if something went wrong at the table she put her hand on the cloth, and it stopped going wrong.

II. The Botánica

Calle Comercio · February

There were three men in the back of Botánica Los Tres Reyes after closing, among the plaster saints and the bundles of herbs and the bottles of bath oil with names on them like Abre Camino and Vence Batalla and Dinero Rápido, and they were adding up what they had lost.

Wiso Medina owned the botánica. Papo Rentas had a little centro of his own in the back of his house where the spirits charged forty dollars for a cleansing and a hundred and fifty for a work against an enemy. The third was a man from the next town who called himself Hermano Ezequiel and sold prayers by the week. Business had been bad for a year. Not everyone who sold herbs and candles on that coast was a thief; most of them were not; there was a woman with a botánica two streets over who sent half her customers up the hill to Luz y Verdad and told them to keep their money. But these three had been living on the fears of the people of that coast for a long time, and the fears had gone up the hill.

It's him, said Wiso. *It's all him. He goes over there and comes back and tells them who's in the light and who's in the dark and why, and they believe him. He tells them for nothing. And then they don't need us.*

So what do we do?

He's sixty-two years old, said Wiso. *He lives alone up on the hill.*

Nobody said anything for a while. Then Hermano Ezequiel said, *That's the way,* and they all three said it, one after the other, and it was decided.

They went around to the people who still came to them, and to the men who owed them, and they raised a thousand dollars. They took it in an envelope to the basketball court behind the caserío Las Gardenias, where the boys who were on the needle sat on the bleachers in the afternoon waiting for the evening, and they found one called Chiqui, who had four others with him.

The old man at Piedra Negra, Wiso said. *The medium. Go up there and finish him.*

The envelope was very thick. Chiqui counted it twice, and said yes, and the other four said yes, and they went.

III. The Keyhole

Piedra Negra · February and March

They came up the hill the first time on a Tuesday night with a car jack handle and two lengths of pipe and a baseball bat, and surrounded the house, one at each corner and Chiqui at the door, and Chiqui put his shoulder to the door and broke it in.

The house was empty. The bed had been slept in. The coffee pot on the stove was still warm. The windows were shut and barred from inside, as they always were, and the back door was bolted from inside, and the front door had been locked from inside with the key still in it until Chiqui broke it.

Doña Lula Pabón, who lived below on the cane road and was up at that hour with her sugar, told it afterward to anybody who would listen. She had seen the light go off in his window and the boys come up around the house in the dark. And she had seen, at the front door, at the height of a man's waist, something come out of the keyhole like a thread of smoke from a cigar, white in the moonlight, and stretch out long and thin along the porch rail, and go down the steps and away across the cane toward the town. She said it was him. Half the barrio believed her and the other half said she should check her sugar again. Celestino, when he was asked, said only that he had spent the night in town.

They came back three weeks later, on a Saturday, and surrounded the house again. This time they did not break in the door. They waited until they could hear him inside, moving around, the radio on, a novela, and then all five of them went in at once, through the door and through the back and through the window over the sink.

He was not in the room. But one of the five, a boy called Tato, who was standing by the bed, would say years later in prison, where people say a great many things, that he had looked up, and seen one of the zinc sheets of the roof lift on its nails at one corner like the page of a book, and

something white go up out of the gap into the night, very fast, the size and shape of a man in a white shirt. The sheet came down again. The radio went on playing. The novela was the one about the twins.

The barrio talked about nothing else. Two times. Two months. People came up the hill to look at the keyhole and to look at the roof. Children dared each other to put an eye to the keyhole, and when they did they could see straight through the house, through the front room and the kitchen and out the window over the sink, to the black rock behind and the light on the cane beyond it, and nothing else at all.

IV. The Third Month

Piedra Negra · April

In April he did not leave.

He knew they were coming. Everybody in Piedra Negra knew they were coming; the boys from Las Gardenias had been spending Wiso's money all over the south coast and talking while they spent it. Celestino went to the centro that Thursday as usual and sat at the white table and went over and came back and told what he had seen, and afterward in the doorway Doña Monse took hold of his sleeve.

Celestino. Stay in town tonight. Stay at my house.

He put his hand over hers on his sleeve, the scarred one.

No, Doña Monse. This one I owe. I've known it since I was a boy. I didn't know what for, but I knew it was owed. I can't keep going out through the roof.

She looked at him a long time with her small black eyes, and let go.

He went home and made coffee, and sat on the porch in his white guayabera with the cup on the rail and the light on behind him, and watched the cane road. Doña Lula, who was up with her sugar, saw him there. She said afterward he sat very straight, the way he sat at the white table, with his hands open on his knees.

They came at one in the morning. They did not have to break anything this time. He stood up when he saw them on the steps and put the cup down.

What they did to him took a long time, and there were five of them, and they had been paid. They used the pipes and the jack handle and the bat and their boots, and when they were done they kept on, because there is a point where men doing a thing like that stop being able to stop. People in the barrio said afterward that they broke every bone in him, that they broke the bones small, as small as grains of rice, and maybe that was the barrio talking and maybe it was not. When they had finished they thought he was dead. They dragged him around behind the black rock into the guinea grass, where he could not be seen from the road, and left him there, and went down the hill and drove away in Chiqui's cousin's car.

Doña Lula heard it. She called the police from the phone in her kitchen. Nobody came until morning. That was the year the government had sent the police and the National Guard into the caseríos with rifles and helicopters and fences, and on the south coast at one in the morning there was nobody left to send up a hill for an old man.

V. The Glass of Water

Centro Espiritista Luz y Verdad · the same night

There was a session at Luz y Verdad that night after all, a late one, because Doña Monse had not gone home. She had sat down at the head of the white table at eleven with the light off in the front room and two of the older mediums with her, and said the prayer, and waited.

At half past one the door opened and Celestino came in.

All three of them would swear to it as long as they lived, and two of them swore to it to the police. He was in his white guayabera. It was raining outside, the first rain in a month, and he was dry. He walked straight, without the hitch at the hip. He came up the room to the head of the table and bent and kissed Doña Monse's hand, which he had never once done in fifty years.

Doña Monse. I'm going.

You're going, Celestino?

Yes.

Where to?

To Piedra Negra.

She looked at him the way she had in the doorway, and nodded once.

Then give us the session before you go, she said. *Because I am not going to have another one like you to look at.*

He sat down in his place at the white table and put his hand flat on the cloth beside the glass of water.

What happened then the two old mediums told to the police and in the centro and to their grandchildren, and they told it the same way every time. The water in the glass rose. It stood up above the rim of the glass the height of a finger, round and clear, like a lens, and did not spill, and there was a light in it that did not come from anywhere in the room. The white cloth moved as if a wind were under it. And Celestino went over, with his eyes open this time, and did not come back for two hours, and the whole of that time he talked. He told them where everybody was. Their mothers. The children they had lost. The men they had hated. Who was in the light and why, and who was in the dark and why, and how long the dark would last for each of them, and that it would not last forever for any of them, not one. He talked as if he were walking through a big house with every door open, telling them what was in each room.

At half past three he stopped. The water went back down into the glass. He stood up, and kissed Doña Monse's hand again, and went out into the rain and down the steps, and the rain did not wet his shirt, and he walked away up the street toward the cane.

Doña Monse sat at the head of the table until it was light. Then she went home and put on her good black dress.

They found him behind the rock at seven in the morning, in the guinea grass, in the rain. The forensic doctor said he had been dead since about one.

VI. The Cafétín

The old cane road · May

It went all over the island. It was in the San Juan papers with a photograph of the rock. Medium beaten to death at Piedra Negra.

Teniente Edgardo Rosa of the district police had been at the white table at Luz y Verdad exactly once, three years before, after his son Eddie was shot outside a club in Ponce. Celestino had gone over and come back and told him where Eddie was and why, and some of it was a thing about Eddie that the lieutenant had not known and did not want to know, and some of it was a message, in words only Eddie used. The lieutenant had never gone back. He had never forgotten it either. When he heard about Piedra Negra he put two men in plain clothes into the cafétíns along the cane road with orders to play dominoes and drink Medalla and listen.

It took three weeks. The boys from Las Gardenias were in a cafétín called El Guayacán on a Friday night, spending the last of Wiso's money, and Chiqui shoved Tato off his stool, and Tato got up off the floor with his lip bleeding.

What did you hit me for?

Because you're a thief and a liar, said Chiqui. *You hit the old man first and you said it was me.*

You don't know who hit him first. You were behind the bat.

I hit him first. Me. With the jack handle.

You hit air with the jack handle. I hit him.

And then all five of them were shouting it, standing up, knocking over the beer, *I hit him, it was me, I hit him first,* the way boys will fight over who scored, and the two men at the domino table in the corner looked at each other and put down their tiles.

The lieutenant had the five of them brought into his own office at the precinct. He asked them one question each. *Was it you that killed the old man at Piedra Negra?* Each of them said yes, because by then each of them was proud of it. Then he asked who paid. They told him that too.

• • •

What happened after that was never in El Vocero.

The five boys were never booked. Wiso Medina and Papo Rentas and Hermano Ezequiel were picked up by men in a car with no markings on a Tuesday night, and the botánica on Calle Comercio burned down on Wednesday, with the plaster saints in it and the bottles of Abre Camino and Dinero Rápido exploding one after another in the heat like firecrackers, and the fire department took forty minutes to come. Their wives went to the precinct and were told there was no record.

The people who lived along the old cane road said, and still say, that on that Tuesday night there was a fire in the dead cane at the colonia they called Las Ochenta, out past the last of the irrigation ditches, where nobody had cut for two years. Cane fires were nothing that dry season. But this one had trucks around it before it started, and men standing in the light of it with rifles, and people say that eight men were put into the dry irrigation ditch there, waist deep, and the dead cane trash was piled over them and lit. And that the next week a contractor came with a tractor and a disc harrow and ran it over that whole field, over and over, back and forth, in the middle of the dry season, when there was nothing to plant.

Nobody was ever charged. The newspapers said eight men from the south coast had disappeared, and that some people believed they had gone to New York.

Doña Monse went to see Chiqui's mother in Las Gardenias, through the fence and past the Guard at the gate, and sat with her in her kitchen for an afternoon. She went to see the others too, one at a time, all eight. Nobody knew what she said to them. When people in the centro asked her about the fire, all she would do was read them one answer out of the book on the white table, and close it.

> *Is murder a crime in the sight of God?*
>
> *Yes, a great crime; for he who takes the life of his fellow-man cuts short an expiation or a mission; hence the heinousness of his offence.*
>
> *— Allan Kardec, The Spirits' Book, 746*

VII. The Debt

Luz y Verdad · a Thursday in June

The centro was full every Thursday that summer, and none of the mediums could do what he had done, and everybody knew it, and at the end of the sessions people stayed and talked.

He didn't deserve it, they said. *A man like that. That death. He never hurt anybody in his life.*

Doña Monse was putting away the white cloth. She folded it in half, and in half again.

If you look at this life only, she said, *no. He didn't deserve it.*

They waited. She did not often say more than that, and they did not expect her to. But she put the cloth down on the table and sat down and put her hand flat on it, the way Celestino used to, and closed her eyes. And then she told them, plainly, the way you tell what you saw at the market.

A long time ago, she said, before any of them were born, in the year the Americans came, there was a young man up in the coffee mountains above Yauco who took care of his father and mother with his own two hands. They were both blind. He picked coffee on shares and worked his own little plot and came home every night and cooked for them and washed their clothes and led them out into the sun in the morning and back in at night. His parents said, Son, you are killing yourself, let us find you a wife. And he said, As long as you live, I will take care of you myself. But they kept on at him, and in the end they found him a wife and brought her home.

For a few weeks she was good to the old people. Then she could not stand the sight of them. She began, when he was out in the coffee, to throw ashes and coffee husks and the starchy water from the rice all over the floor of the house, and when he came home she would say, Look what your blind old people have done. Look at the filth. I cannot live in the same house with them. She said it every night. And in the end, she wore him down, a good man, a man who had done everything right until then, and he turned against his own father and mother.

Never mind, he told her. *I'll take care of it.*

Those were the months when the night bands were in the mountains, the ones they called tiznados, who came down on the haciendas and the stores. He told his parents that their cousins in another barrio wanted to see them, and put them in the oxcart, and drove them out on the mountain road. Deep in the woods he gave the reins to his father. Hold these, Papá. The oxen know the road. This is where the tiznados wait for people. I am going to get down and look. And he went into the trees, and blacked his face with charcoal from an old fire, and began to shout, first one voice and then many voices, louder and louder, until it sounded like a whole band coming down through the woods. And his father and mother, sitting blind in the cart, called out to him: Son! Son, we are old! Save yourself! Don't worry about us, run! And he came out of the trees with his face black and beat them to death with a stick, and threw them down into the ravine, and drove the cart home.

The centro was very quiet.

That was Celestino? somebody said finally.

That was the spirit that came back as Celestino, said Doña Monse. *He paid for it a long time in the dark first. Then he came back, again and again, and every time it was paid the same way, with a stick, in the dark, by people he never did anything to. This was the last time. He knew. He didn't know what for, but he knew it was owed. That's why he didn't go out through the roof.*

She opened the book that always lay on the white table, the old Kardec with its cover held on by tape, and found the place without looking for it, and read.

> *The vicissitudes of corporeal life being at once an expiation of the faults of the past and lessons for the future, can we, from the nature of those vicissitudes, infer the character of our preceding existence?*
>
> *You can do so very frequently, since the nature of the punishment incurred always corresponds to that of the fault committed.*
>
> *— Allan Kardec, The Spirits' Book, 399*

Then she closed it, and got up, and finished folding the cloth.

• • •

Nobody has lived in the house at Piedra Negra since. The government took the land along with the rest of the cane, and nobody has come to build anything on it yet. The door still has the lock Chiqui broke and nobody fixed.

The children still climb the hill on dares to put their eye to the keyhole. You can see straight through the house from there, through the front room and the kitchen and the window over the sink, to the black rock behind it, and past the rock to the cane going down to the sea. Toward evening the sun gets low enough to come all the way through, and lays a little round coin of light on the cheek of whoever is looking, and they come running back down the hill with it still on their faces.

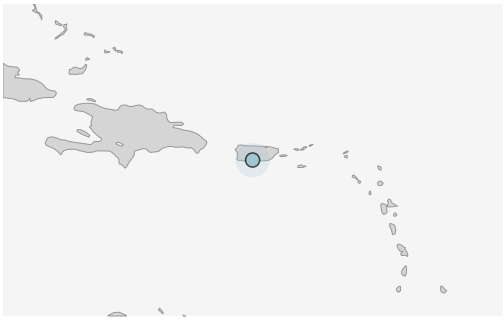
Background

The verses

> *He who inflicts pain on innocent and harmless persons, will soon come to one of these ten states:*
>
> Dhammapada 137, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)
>
> *He will have cruel suffering, loss, injury of the body, heavy affliction, or loss of mind,*
>
> Dhammapada 138, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)
>
> *Or a misfortune coming from the king, or a fearful accusation, or loss of relations, or destruction of treasures,*
>
> Dhammapada 139, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)
>
> *Or lightning-fire will burn his houses; and when his body is destroyed, the fool will go to hell.*
>
> Dhammapada 140, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Mahā Moggallāna, one of the Buddha's two chief disciples, visits the heavens and the hells and comes back to tell people what deeds lead where, and the offerings flow to the Buddha's community. Rival ascetics pay a thousand coins to bandits to kill him at Black Rock. Twice he escapes, once through a keyhole and once through the roof, but in the third month he stays, knowing an old deed has come due. The bandits break his bones as small as grains of rice and leave him for dead. He pulls himself together, flies to the Buddha to take leave, teaches and works wonders one last time, and returns to Black Rock to die. The killers are caught when

they brawl in a tavern over who struck him first, and King Ajātasattu has them and the ascetics burned in pits and plowed under. The Buddha explains that in a past life Moggallāna, turned by his wife against his blind parents, beat them to death in a forest while pretending to be bandits. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Moggallāna.



South coast, Puerto Rico

The south coast of Puerto Rico, *1994*

Espiritismo came to Puerto Rico in the nineteenth century through the books of the French writer Allan Kardec, and grew into many forms, from strict Kardecist centros to folk practice mixed with Catholic, African and Taíno elements. At the mesa blanca, the white table, a medium hosts a spirit so that those seated can ask it questions. Kardec's *The Spirits' Book* (1857), written as questions put to spirits and their answers, teaches that spirits are reborn many times and that the trials of one life answer to the faults of earlier ones. Celestino's past life falls in 1898, after the United States invaded Puerto Rico, when night bands called partidas sediciosas, or tiznados, raided the haciendas and stores of Spaniards in the mountains of the interior.

Sugar had ruled the south coast for a century. The great mill at Central Aguirre, between Salinas and Guayama, ran from 1899 until it closed for good in 1993, and by then the industry had been failing for decades. In 1993 Governor Pedro Rosselló began the anti-crime campaign called Mano Dura, the hard hand. Between June 1993 and March 1999 police and the National Guard carried out about eighty raids on public housing projects, each followed by an occupation that lasted weeks, with checkpoints, helicopters and fences around the projects, as the scholar Marisol LeBrón describes in the Boston Review.

After the story of the Elder Mahā Moggallāna from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 137–140). The original. Scripture from Allan Kardec's *The Spirits' Book*, translated by Anna Blackwell (Boston: Colby and Rich, 1893). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.8

Sin Vergüenza

Y rasgad vuestros corazones, y no vuestros vestidos.
And rend your hearts, and not your garments.
— Joel 2:13

The way it came around the fire, on the Rio San Antonio.

I. The Outfit

Bus Village, Carson National Forest, New Mexico · the last week of June 1995

Lyle Hoagland's wife died in October, in the hospital in Alamosa, and by Christmas he knew he could not stay in the house. He was sixty-four. He had raised malting barley and seed potatoes on three quarters outside Manassa, in the San Luis Valley of Colorado. For twelve seasons in the middle of his life he had also been the water commissioner on the Conejos, which meant that from May to September he drove the river and its ditches in a state pickup and shut the headgates of men he had known since grade school. He had been good at both trades and they had left him well off. In February he sold the ground, and the water with it, to a neighbor's son.

Ardith had gone once to one of the Gatherings. That was the first one, in 1972, over the mountains at Strawberry Lake. Her sister talked her into it. She was gone five days and came home sunburned, wearing a string of clay beads, and for a month afterward she would stop in the middle of the dishes and laugh. All she ever told him about it was that nobody up there had asked her what her husband did. He found the beads in her dresser in January. In April a boy at the feed store in Antonito, with hair to his belt, told him the Family was coming to the Carson that summer, to the head of the Rio San Antonio, forty miles of road from where the two of

them stood. Lyle took it as a thing addressed to him. He told people he was through with all of it, that he was going up to live with the Rainbows and own nothing. He meant it. He had meant everything he ever said.

Then he got ready. He bought a thirty-one-foot Winnebago with an Onan generator under the floor. Behind it he pulled a trailer with his elk-camp outfit, which was a wall tent fourteen by sixteen, a second tent for a cookhouse, a four-burner propane range and a chest freezer that ran off the Onan. Half a beef went into the freezer. Into the wall tent went a sixty-pound tin of valley honey, ten pounds of butter, two gallons of olive oil, flour, coffee and a case of green chile. He hired Benny Archuleta, who had irrigated for him nineteen years, and Benny's wife Ernestina, at sixty dollars a day apiece, to come along and keep the camp. Ernestina was the best cook between Antonito and the state line. Lyle had eaten at her table every harvest since 1976 and did not see why he should stop.

The way in was Forest Road 87, which leaves the highway north of Tres Piedras, under San Antonio Mountain, and runs west for eighteen miles of gravel and cattle guards. At the far end the Family had laid out parking in a long meadow. Beside the parking was a place for people who lived in their vehicles, which was called Bus Village, and the Gathering itself lay three miles farther on by foot trail, in the meadows along the river. Lyle looked at the trail and at the Winnebago and set up where he was. Benny leveled the rig and pitched the tents under the firs. Ernestina had beans on by dark.

At the gate a girl with bells on her ankles had put her arms around him and said, *Welcome home.* He stood for it. A man on the parking crew walked the length of the Winnebago and said mildly that the Family didn't really do generators, brother, or money. Lyle said he understood. He ran the Onan four hours a day, on account of the freezer.

He had two sets of clothes for the new life. In the daytime he wore what he had bought for it in Taos, drawstring trousers of unbleached cotton, a shirt with no collar, sandals, and Ardith's beads. The meadow lay at better than nine thousand feet, and when the cold came down off the ridge at sundown he changed into wool trousers, a flannel shirt, a down vest and sheepskin slippers. He slept in the rig, between sheets, under

two of his mother's quilts. Twice in the first week he walked down to the Gathering and stood at the edge of the big meadow at suppertime. Several thousand people sat there in rings on the ground, eating rice and lentils that were ladled out of plastic buckets into whatever bowl each one had brought. He watched it to the end both times and then walked the three miles back to Ernestina's cooking. He told himself he would go down for good once he had the hang of it.

II. The Line

Bus Village · July 2

They kept coming. By the second of July the rangers were guessing fifteen thousand, with the Fourth still ahead. The good ground near the river was taken, and people arriving late went looking along the edges.

Four of them came up through the firs that morning. One was a woman of forty or so called Marigold, who cooked at Kid Village. There was a couple from Arkansas with a baby in a sling. The fourth was a boy of about nineteen that people called Sonny Rich, who had been on the land nine days. He had made it his business to eat at every kitchen and to ask whoever was stirring the pot what was the main thing they had found out so far. The four of them walked out of the trees into Lyle's camp and stopped.

Ernestina had washed that morning. Benny had strung a hundred feet of rope from the awning to a fir, and it was full. There were two cotton shirts on it and two flannel, the drawstring trousers and the wool ones, four sheets, six towels, both quilts, a down comforter, a bathrobe, and two sleeping bags, one for cold nights and one for colder. Past the line stood the wall tents. Through the door of one they could see the white corner of the freezer, and they could hear the generator.

Whose is all this, brother? Marigold said. She thought it might be a kitchen she hadn't heard about.

Mine.

All of it?

All of it.

The boy was counting shirts. Marigold looked at the line for a while. *You know what we say coming in,* she said. *We walk lightly on the land. A bowl, a cup and a spoon, something to sleep in, and what you can carry down the trail. There are kids down there sleeping under a sheet of plastic, and they think they're rich. You've come home, brother. You brought the whole house.*

And two people on wages, Sonny Rich said. He had seen Benny splitting wood behind the cook tent and Ernestina at the range. *Nobody pays anybody here. That's sort of the entire thing.*

They are paid fair, Lyle said.

I bet they are.

Marigold was not angry and did not pretend to be. *Walk down with us,* she said. *There's council after dinner circle. We'll put it in front of the Family. That's all we ever do about anything. Nobody is going to make you do one thing.*

He went. He had held hearings on ditch banks for twelve years and had never ducked one.

The trail dropped through aspen and came out above the river, and he saw by daylight what he had seen only from the edge. The kitchens stood along the meadow under tarps, with their names painted on boards, Lovin' Ovens, Tea Time, Granola Funk. Down at the river the Family had dammed a pool and dug a mud bath beside it. Thirty people lay on the bank coated gray to the eyes, drying like adobes. A man went by with his hair in ropes that hung to the backs of his knees. A girl sat outside the healers' camp with a card around her neck that said she was fasting and silent until noon on the Fourth. On a flat rock above the trail a man squatted on his heels facing the sun, and the boy said he had been there since it came up. Two people were asleep on the bare ground at midday with nothing under them. A good many people wore no clothes at all, and nobody looked at them. The trails had been walked to powder, so that everyone, dressed or not, was the same color to the knee.

Beside the trail ran a line of white plastic pipe. It came down off the east slope from somewhere in the timber, and at each kitchen a tee went off to a spigot with a filter can under it.

That's Chuy's, Sonny Rich said. *The water. He's done it since Arizona.*

III. The Circle

Main Meadow · that evening

Somebody blew a conch shell at the hour when the light went long, and the meadow filled. The kitchens carried their buckets in. People sat down in rings around the fire pit, ring outside ring, and the servers went along the rows. Musicians walked the Magic Hat around behind them.

There were other people in the meadow that evening. All week families had been driving in from Tres Piedras and Vallecitos and the plazas up along the Colorado line to see it for themselves. They stood along the edge in clean shirts with their arms folded. Their people had three hundred years in that country, and the Forest Service wrote them a ticket for a pickup load of firewood without a permit. Now they were watching eighteen thousand strangers build a town in the elk pasture without asking anyone. Among them stood a small old woman in a blue headscarf with two grandchildren by the hands. She had come eighty miles round from Conejos County because her nephew was mixed up in this. She wanted to see what he did every July instead of helping with the first cutting.

Her nephew was Jesús Maestas, called Chuy, who was forty-six and a plumber in Antonito. He had been born in a plaza of fourteen houses on the lower San Antonio, on the Colorado side, where this same water was turned out of the river into his family's ditch after it had run north across the line. In the Army he had kept the water point for an engineer battalion. He came home in 1970 and had not said a great deal since. He walked into the Gathering in Arizona in 1979 behind a girl from Tucson. The girl went home. Chuy had seen a kitchen dipping its water out of a creek below the latrines, and he stayed and fixed that. He had laid the line at every Gathering since. Seed camp had him three weeks before anyone else came, finding the springs, and he was always among the last off the land. He could have quit any year, and the people who had been to all sixteen said the water would not have been fit to drink.

He was sitting on an upturned bucket at the edge of the inner ring, with a hacksaw and a can of pipe cement by his foot, when Marigold brought Lyle in. He looked up and knew him. Lyle knew the face without the name. It was Eliseo Maestas's boy.

Marigold took the feather and told it the way things are told in council, without meanness, and left nothing out. She told about the clothesline, the two tents, the freezer and the generator, the two cooks on wages, and two of everything. *This brother says he has come home for good,* she said. *I believe him. I just don't know what he thinks home is.* She passed the feather on. It went around a little, and then people looked at Chuy, as they did when a question was practical.

Don Lyle, Chuy said. *Is that how it is?*

It is. It's all so.

How come? You told the boy at the feed store you were coming up here to own nothing. He's my cousin's kid.

It was a small thing to say, and there was no edge on it. But Lyle Hoagland was sixty-four years old. He had been walked three miles in sandals to be read out in front of ten thousand barefoot strangers and a neighbor's son, and the blood came up in his face.

Well, then, he said. *If that's what is wanted.*

He pulled the collarless shirt over his head and threw it down. He stepped out of the drawstring trousers and kicked the sandals after them. He stood there in the middle of the circle in his undershorts, white as a root from the neck down, with his arms brown to the elbow.

There, he said. *Is that little enough? I'll go around like this.*

Nobody gasped. There were two hundred people in that meadow wearing less, and some of them were sitting within reach of him. Nobody there minded skin. What stopped the talk was the way he had thrown the shirt. It landed at Chuy's feet, thrown the way a man throws down money when he believes he is being robbed. A child laughed and was hushed. At the edge of the meadow the old woman in the blue scarf took her two grandchildren by the shoulders and turned them to face the trees.

Chuy got up off the bucket. He picked up the shirt and shook the dust out of it and stood holding it.

My father cursed you every summer for twelve years, he said. *In 'seventy-seven the river didn't make half its water and you had the call on by the tenth of June. You shut us off with the hay half up. You chained the gate and hung your tag on it. He said things about you I won't repeat in front of my aunt.*

I remember it, Lyle said.

Then he would say the other thing, and he said it every time. Ese tiene vergüenza. *That one has shame. He said you never locked a gate without coming to the door first, with your hat in your hand, to say what you were doing and whose right the water was going to. You never came at night. You never did it in front of a man's children. In 'seventy-seven you shut off your own brother-in-law the same morning you shut us. For twelve years the whole river hated the sight of your truck, and nobody on it could say you had shamed him. You had a lock in your hand that whole time, and you kept your shame.*

He held out the shirt.

Now you come up here to the Family, where nobody is asking you for anything but the truth, and you throw it down in the dirt in front of these kids and my tía. She is calling you a sinvergüenza over there right now. I can hear her. Put your clothes on, Don Lyle.

Lyle stood where he was. The color left his face and came back more slowly. He took the shirt and put it on. He got into the trousers, which took some time on one leg, and nobody helped him and nobody laughed. Then he turned toward the edge of the meadow and said, *I beg your pardon, ma'am,* loud enough to carry. He came back to the inner ring and let himself down onto the ground beside Chuy's bucket, and sat with his stiff knees up, like a man who has come late into church.

IV. The Thing in the Lake

Main Meadow · the same night

It was Sonny Rich who asked. He said that where he came from, shame was the thing people came up here to get rid of, and he would like to know what Chuy's father had meant by it.

Chuy thought about that for some time. He said it was a different word. He said he couldn't explain it and never had been able to, but his

grandmother had a story she told when she wanted the children to have it. The drums had stopped. He told it the way she did, with his hands on his knees, and he did not hurry.

There was a rico on the Chama who had two sons. Their mother died and he married again, and the second wife gave him a third. The day that boy was born the old man was so pleased that he told her she could ask him for anything. She said she would ask later.

When her son was grown she asked. She wanted the ranch for him, all of it. The old man said no. *My two older boys walk around this country like two fires burning,* he said. *I can't put them out for yours.* She asked again every week. He began to be afraid of what she might do. So he called the two older sons and told them how it was. *Go up into the sierra and stay there,* he said. *When I am dead, come down and take what is yours.*

They kissed his hand and went. In the yard their little brother was playing. He saw them go by with their blankets rolled, found out why, and went with them.

High in the mountains the eldest sat down under a tree. He said to the youngest, *There is a lake down there. Go wash, and drink, and bring us some water back in your hat.*

Now that lake belonged to a thing. Whoever it is that hands out such places had given it the lake, with one rule. It could keep anybody who came down into the water, except a person who knew who God's own people are. So it asked that of everyone who came.

The boy waded in and the thing rose up and asked him. He said, *The sun and the moon.* It said, *You don't know,* and took him under and shut him in its house at the bottom.

When he did not come back the eldest sent the second brother. The thing asked him too. He said, *The four directions.* It said, *You don't know,* and took him down to the same place.

Some of the people around the fire shifted a little at that, because they had been honoring the four directions every morning for a week. Chuy went on.

The eldest waited and then went down himself. He saw two sets of tracks going into the water and none coming out, and he knew what kind

of lake it was. He put his knife in his belt and stood on the bank and would not go in.

The thing saw he was not coming, so it came to him. It made itself a woodcutter with an ax on its shoulder. *Friend, you look tired,* it said. *Why don't you go in and wash, and drink, and cool off?*

It was you that took my brothers.

It was.

Why?

I take everybody who goes down in. Everybody but the ones who know who God's own people are.

Do you want to know that?

I do, said the thing.

I can't tell it dirty like this, off the road.

So the thing washed him and brought him water to drink. It gave him a clean shirt and sat him on a bench in the shade. Then it sat down on the ground at his feet.

Listen, then, the eldest said. *The ones who have shame, and are afraid to do wrong even with nobody looking. Quiet people, clean underneath. Those are God's own in this world. There aren't any others.*

The thing believed him. *You can have one brother back,* it said. *Which?*

The little one.

You know it and you don't do it, said the thing. *You pass over your full brother, who is older, for your stepmother's boy.*

I know it and I do it. We are in these mountains on that boy's account. His mother wanted the ranch for him. If I go home without him and say a thing in a lake ate him, who will believe me? I couldn't walk past a door in that valley.

Take both, the thing said. *You are the one who knows.*

It brought both brothers up. The eldest sat a while longer and told the thing what a life it had there, eating travelers, and the thing listened to him and gave it up. It kept watch over the three of them in the mountains after that. When the old man died they went down, and the thing went with them. The eldest took the ranch. He made one brother his mayordomo and the other his caporal. For the thing he built a little house in a good place by the ditch and saw that it never went without.

My grandma said it lived there twelve years, Chuy said, *and in twelve years nobody saw it do a thing it would have minded being seen at. She said that kind comes around again. You can tell them. They stand by the water and ask everybody the same question.*

What's your number, Lyle said, to nobody.

It was what he had asked at every headgate on the Conejos, twelve summers. He meant the priority, the year a ditch was decreed, which settled who drank in a dry year.

V. Ash Wednesday

Main Meadow · later

THE FIRE HAD BEEN BUILT UP. SONNY RICH WAS NOT FINISHED. He wanted to know what did it, then. He said he had been to every kitchen. He had talked to the girl who was fasting, and the man on the rock, and the mud people, and he had half a mind to go without clothes till the Fourth himself.

Go ahead, Chuy said. *It's warm enough in the daytime.*

He turned the can of pipe cement around on the ground with his foot.

I've been coming sixteen years, he said. *I've seen people go the whole week with nothing on. I've seen hair that never met a comb, and that mud at the river. I've seen people who don't eat till the Fourth, and people who sleep on the rocks on purpose. That man sits on his heels up there every year from sunup to dark. Most of them are good people and I've got nothing against any of it. But I never saw it wash anybody. If a man still doesn't know what he came for, he goes home the same as he came. He's dirtier, or he's thinner.*

He looked at Lyle.

The freezer isn't it either, Don Lyle. You could give every bit of it away tonight and you'd still be standing there in your shorts.

Then he told about his father. Eliseo Maestas had been an Hermano of the morada above the plaza for fifty years. On Good Friday he went up to it on his knees over the rocks with the others, and there was more that Chuy said he would not tell. His father had believed in it and had done it until he was seventy. His people had come up from the Cañada in the

1850s, and they still told about a hermano down there in the old days who belonged to no brotherhood at all, and lived in a hut under the black mesa, and people went to sit with him anyway. Every Ash Wednesday, when the family came back from church with the ashes on their foreheads, Eliseo said the same thing at the table. It was out of the reading for the day.

> *Y rasgad vuestros corazones, y no vuestros vestidos.*
>
> *— Joel 2:13, tr. Félix Torres Amat (1825)*
>
> *And rend your hearts, and not your garments.*
>
> *— Joel 2:13, Douay-Rheims*

He said the rocks were for him, and God had no use for them. He said he had known men to come down from the morada on Friday with their backs open and be the same sinvergüenzas on Saturday morning. It's not the clothes. On you or off you, it's not the clothes.

A girl came running from Tea Time to say a fitting had let go and the kitchen was flooding. Chuy picked up his hacksaw and went.

Lyle sat on until the fire was low. The local people were leaving by the upper trail with flashlights. The old woman in the blue scarf stopped beside him with the children, looked him over, and said something in Spanish across his head to Marigold, who had some.

She says her brother was right about you, Marigold said. *And that you're too thin. And that she didn't see anything.*

VI. The Spring

The Rio San Antonio · July 3 to August 4

He walked back up in the dark. In the morning he shut off the Onan, and the four of them emptied the camp, Benny and Ernestina and Lyle and the boy, who had turned up at sunrise without being asked. The food at Main Circle was vegetarian, so the beef went to a kitchen by the parking lot that fed the gate crew. The honey, butter, oil and flour went down the trail to Supply on a garden cart. The quilts went to

Kid Village and the comforter to the healers. The cotton trousers and the collarless shirt went into the free bin, and were seen all that week on a tall man from Oregon.

He paid Benny and Ernestina through the month and asked Benny to drive the Winnebago home and sell it. Ernestina would not leave until she had seen where her beans were going. She followed the cart down, looked into the kitchen at Lovin' Ovens, and took an apron off a nail. She made tortillas there for two days for some nine hundred people. Nobody paid her, and she talked about how those children kept a kitchen for the rest of her life.

Lyle kept the wool trousers and the flannel shirt, because of the nights. He kept one sleeping bag, and a bowl, a cup and a spoon out of the Winnebago's drawer, and Ardith's beads.

On the Fourth the whole Gathering was silent from sunrise. He woke on the ground at the edge of the meadow and lay looking along the grass. Every blade had a drop of dew on it, and in every drop he could see the meadow upside down, the tents and the smoke of the kitchens and all the other drops. Toward noon the people came down out of the trees from every side and joined hands in a circle so wide that he could not see the far side of it. He stood in it between Marigold and a man still gray from the river. The sound they made together began low and lasted a long while. Then the children came in from Kid Village in a parade, and everyone shouted. He said later that he had not felt a great deal, and that nobody had asked him what he did.

By the seventh most of them were gone. About fifty stayed, as some always do, and Lyle stayed with them. The summer rains came, better than seven inches before they were through. He filled latrines and scattered the stones of fire rings. He broke up the packed ground of the kitchens with a digging bar and laid slash across the new trails so they would not wash. He walked fifteen miles of Forest Road 87 with a sack and picked up mufflers and windshield glass. He slept in the one bag. Chuy worked beside him most days and said about as much as he ever did.

The water came out last. They pulled the pipe from the bottom up, cut it at the couplings and coiled what would coil, and on the fourth of Au-

gust, with the ranger from Tres Piedras walking the meadows below them, they climbed to the highest spring. Chuy unbolted the box. The two of them lifted out the plastic liner and carried it off, and left the hollow in the ground the way it was, for the elk.

The water stood in it a minute, brown, and then cleared. It rose to the low place in the rim and went over. It ran down through the bent grass toward the river, which runs north there, over the line and past the Maestas gate into the Conejos.

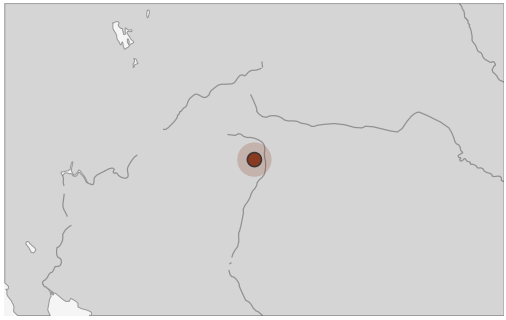
Lyle watched it out of sight. He had on the flannel shirt, which had not been washed since the Fourth, and his hands were empty.

Background

The verse

> *Not nakedness, not platted hair, not dirt, not fasting, or lying on the earth, not rubbing with dust, not sitting motionless, can purify a mortal who has not overcome desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 141, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a householder of Sāvatthī becomes a monk after his wife dies, but first has a cell, a kitchen and a storeroom built for himself, fills the storeroom with ghee, honey and oil, and sends for his own slaves to cook for him. He keeps one set of robes for the day and another for the night. Monks looking for lodging see his robes and bedding hung out to dry and bring him before the Buddha, who asks how a man gone forth under a teaching of wanting little came to own so much. Stung, the monk throws off his outer robe in the middle of the assembly and says he will go about like that. The Buddha reminds him that once, even as a water demon, he kept his sense of shame and fear of wrongdoing for twelve years; the monk covers himself and sits down. The Buddha then tells the birth story of the three princes and the demon of the lake, who released his captives when the eldest told him that the godlike are those who have conscience and concern (hiri and ottappa), and ends with the verse on the ascetic practices that cleanse no one. Read the full commentary story. The birth story is the Devadhamma Jātaka, the sixth of the Jātaka collection. Müller's "desires" in the last clause renders a word the commentary takes as doubt.



Carson National Forest, New Mexico

The Rio San Antonio, 1995

The Rainbow Family of Living Light has gathered on national forest land in the first week of July every year since 1972, when the first Gathering was held at Strawberry Lake in Colorado. It has no leaders, members or fees; no money changes hands on the land; kitchens are fed from a common Supply paid for by the Magic Hat; each person brings a bowl, a cup and a spoon; and the Family's own handbook says that generators are not appropriate to a Gathering and asks everyone to walk lightly on the earth. The 1995 Gathering was held on the Tres Piedras Ranger District of the Carson National Forest, at the head of the Rio San Antonio, eighteen miles in on Forest Road 87. The Forest Service estimated more than 18,000 people. The district ranger's cleanup letter of November 3, 1995 records Bus Village and its three to four miles of new trail, the mud baths and pools on the river, the spring boxes and PVC pipe, the fifty or so people who stayed from July 7 to August 4 to restore the site, more than seven inches of rain, and the spring depressions left as wildlife water. It also records the feeling of the Hispano villages nearby, some of whose residents protested the Gathering, and their advice that the Family "needs to listen more than talk."

The Rio San Antonio runs north out of New Mexico and joins the Conejos in Colorado's San Luis Valley, where water is divided by prior appropriation: in a short year the oldest decreed ditches drink first, and a state water commissioner closes the headgates of the junior ones. The winter of 1976–77 brought one of the worst droughts in Colorado's record. *Vergüenza* in the Spanish of the upper Rio Grande means a sense of honor and of what is owed to other people, and a *sinvergüenza* is someone who has lost it. The lay brotherhood of the Penitentes has kept its moradas and its Holy Week penances in these villages since Spanish times. The passage from Joel is the old reading for Ash Wednesday; the Spanish here is from the Catholic translation of Félix Torres Amat. Lyle Hoagland, Chuy Maestas and his family, Marigold and Sonny Rich are invented, and so is the plaza on the lower San Antonio.

After the story of the bhikkhu with many possessions from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 141). The original. Scripture from the Spanish Bible of Félix Torres Amat (1825) and the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

10.9

Seven Palms

> *...for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.*
> *— 1 Samuel 16:7*

Ua lohe au penei, on the Waikīkī road.

I. The Freedom of the Town

Honolulu · November 1886

In the spring of that year there was trouble in the Kona uplands, the kind that had been coming for twenty years. A ranch had let its cattle into the taro patches of a whole valley, season after season, and when the planters began to spear the cattle the ranch hired men from town who carried pistols. A house burned. A boy was shot through the arm. The sheriff in Kailua wrote to Honolulu that he could not answer for what came next, and in Honolulu somebody remembered Kimo Haʻaheo.

He was forty years old and had been a cowboy on the Big Island since he was twenty, the best roper between Waimea and Kaʻū, a big man with a quiet voice and a rawhide quirt he wore looped at his wrist the way other men wore a watch chain. They swore him in as a deputy and sent him up the mountain. He was there eleven weeks. He rode into the valley alone the first day and into the ranch yard alone the second, and before he was done he had used the quirt on men from both sides, and broken one man's collarbone with the butt of it, and taken eleven pistols away from the ranch's hired men and thrown them in the sea off Keauhou. Nobody else was shot. The cattle went behind a stone wall that the ranch paid for. The planters went back to their patches. People in Kona said it

was the first time anybody had seen the law come down that mountain on the side of a taro patch.

The King heard about it. The King liked a story, and he liked a man who could ride, and he was about to turn fifty.

So on the morning of the sixteenth of November, when the police of the kingdom marched up to ʻIolani Palace at sunrise to pay their respects, Kimo Haʻaheo was among them in a new black coat, and he went up the steps into the hall with the life-size portraits of the old kings along the walls and knelt, and the King pinned a cross on a ribbon to his coat. It was gold and blue enamel, the Royal Order of Kalākaua, Companion class. On the back of it, around the date, was one word worked in gold. *KEOLA*. The life.

That was the honor. The reward was the jubilee. For the first seven days of it Kimo was to be the King's own guest, and the word went around Honolulu that whatever he wanted, he could have. A cottage on the beach at Waikīkī, with a lānai under the coconuts. A grey horse from the royal stables. His name good at every store on Fort Street and every bar on Nuʻuanu, the bills to go to the palace. And because the hula troupes had come down from all the islands to dance on the palace grounds for the jubilee, as they had for the coronation three years before, a girl from one of the Puna troupes was sent to dance for him in the evenings. Her name was Kēhau. She was nineteen. Her name meant the dew.

Kimo had not been drunk since he was a boy. He was drunk for seven days. He drank champagne at the palace, where the electric lights the King had put in that summer threw a white glare across the lawns, and he drank gin in the saloons on Nuʻuanu Street, and when that ran out he drank ʻōkolehao out of a jug some Kona men had brought down on the steamer, the ti-root liquor that comes out of the old whaling try-pots and takes the skin off your tongue. He watched the fire companies parade with torches. He watched rockets go up off Punchbowl. He bought a silk shirt and a hat with a band of feathers and every morning somebody put a new lei around the brim of it. He slept in the afternoons. In the evenings Kēhau danced for him on the lānai with the surf behind her, and he did

not take his eyes off her, and the quirt stayed looped at his wrist the whole time, because he had forgotten it was there.

II. The Waikīkī Road

Kālia · the seventh morning

Halfway between town and Waikīkī, where the road ran between the fishponds and the Chinese rice fields, there was a frame house with a grass-roofed schoolroom beside it and a coconut grove behind, and an old woman lived there whom the whole road called Kumu, the teacher.

Her name was Lahela. She had been born in the old time, before the kapu fell, and she could remember the year her mother first sat down to eat with her father, and how frightened everybody was, and how nothing happened. When the missionaries came with their letters she was a girl of nine. She learned to read in a month, in the shade of a hau tree, sounding out the words in a little printed primer with her finger, and in the next forty years she taught half of the Waikīkī road to do the same. She taught them in a grass house and then in a frame one. She taught the fishermen's children and the poi-pounders' children and the children of chiefs, and grown men who had been ashamed to come in daylight, and once, for most of a winter, a sea captain from Maine who wanted to read his Hawaiian wife's letters. She went to Kawaiahaʻo on Sundays and sat at the back. She had buried a husband and two sons. She did not talk much, and when she did it was usually short.

She was sitting on her steps that morning shelling ʻopihi into a bowl for her grandson, Ioane, who was ten, when the grey horse came down the road from town at a walk.

Kimo sat it like a chief. The silk shirt was the color of a ripe mango. There were three lei around the hat, maile and ʻilima and something white, and pinned to the shirt on its ribbon, the King's gold cross. His eyes were red. Behind him came half a dozen of his Kona men on their own horses, laughing, with jugs. People came out of the houses along the

road to watch him go by, because by then everybody in Honolulu knew whose guest he was.

He saw Kumu on her steps. He had learned his letters from her, thirty years before, on the same steps. He did not get down. He touched two fingers to the brim of the hat with the lei on it and nodded to her, from up there, and rode on toward the beach.

Kumu watched him go. Then she smiled.

What are you smiling at? said Ioane. *He didn't even get off the horse.*

He'll get off tonight, Kumu said. *He'll come back up this road tonight in that hat and sit down on my floor, and I'll say one verse to him, and when I'm done he'll be finished with all of it. Then he'll go up higher than those palms and go home.* She lifted her chin at the coconut grove behind the schoolroom, where the trees stood fifty and sixty feet over the house. *Today,* she said, and went back to the ʻopihi.

The poi man was going by with his cart and heard it, and a fish woman from the ponds heard it, and by noon it was all over Kālia and halfway to town. At the saloon on the Waikīkī road the men laughed so hard one of them fell off his bench. *Kimo Haʻaheo? Going up in the air? He can't get up off his own lānai.* One of them put a silver dollar on the bar, a new one with the King's face on it, and said the old woman was finished, she had been teaching too long, and anybody who wanted to take his money could take it. By two o'clock there were forty dollars on the bar, most of it against her.

At the church end of the road the women in their long holokū said nothing about money. They looked at each other. Some of them went home and put on their good dresses, and some of them went and got their lanterns ready, just in case.

III. Kēhau

Waikīkī · afternoon

KIMO RODE THE GREY HORSE STRAIGHT INTO THE WATER AT Waikīkī, the way he had seen chiefs do it when he was a boy, and slid off its back in the shallows and swam out past where the waves broke, still in

THE SILK SHIRT. THE KONA MEN CHEERED HIM FROM THE SAND. He lay on his back out there for a long time, under Lēʻahi, with the cross floating on its ribbon on his chest, and let the swells lift him and set him down. Then he came in and slept on the lānai of the King's cottage until the sun was low.

When he woke Kēhau was already there.

She had been dancing every night of the jubilee, at the palace and then for him, and for seven days she had eaten almost nothing. Nobody had asked her to. The Puna troupe was to dance before the King at the great lūʻau, and she wanted to be light for it. She wanted to come down on the boards of the long lānai they had built for the lūʻau as softly as a leaf. She drank water and a little coconut milk, and each day she felt lighter, and each day she danced better, and her teacher in the troupe looked at her and said nothing because she had never seen the girl dance like that.

The sun went down behind Waiʻanae. Somebody lit the lanterns. One of the Kona men took up the gourd drum and Kēhau stood up in her skirt with the green leaves at her wrists and ankles and began.

Kimo could not have said afterward what the dance was. He did not know the old words. He knew that her hands went out over the water as if they were smoothing it, and that the surf came in behind her as if she had called it, and that everybody on the lānai had stopped talking, even the drunkest of the Kona men. She went down on her knees, and rose, and turned, and the lantern light went along her arms.

In the middle of a turn she stopped.

She put both hands flat against her stomach, under her ribs, the way you press a hand to a place where a knife has gone in. She looked at Kimo. Her mouth opened. She went down onto the boards, sideways, without putting out a hand, and lay there with her eyes and her mouth open, and the drum went on for two or three beats more because the man playing it had his eyes shut.

See to her, said Kimo. *See to her. Somebody.*

One of the Kona men knelt by her. He held his hand in front of her mouth, and then he put two fingers on her throat, under the jaw, the way you feel for it in a calf. Then he looked up.

Kimo. She's dead.

Kimo had been drunk for seven days, and in that moment all of it went out of him. It went the way water goes when you throw it on the stones of an imu that has been heating all morning. It hissed, and it was gone, and there was nothing left of it, and he was standing on the lānai stone sober in a wet silk shirt with three lei on his hat, looking at a dead girl.

He stood there a long time. People were crying. Somebody had run for a doctor. Somebody else was saying that it was the fasting, that he had told her and told her. The surf kept coming in.

Kimo thought: There is nobody in this whole kingdom who can put this out. Not the King. Not the doctor. Not the minister at Kawaiahaʻo.

Then he thought of the frame house at Kālia, and the old woman on the steps, and he went and got his hat.

IV. Water on a Hot Stone

Kālia · evening

He walked. He left the grey horse tied at the cottage and walked up the Waikīkī road in the dark with his Kona men behind him, on foot too, leading their horses, not one of them saying anything. Their spurs rang on the coral of the road.

They were not the only ones on it. Word had gone up the road ahead of them, the way word did, and by the time they reached Kālia there were lanterns in Kumu's yard and on the road outside her fence and up among the trunks of the coconut grove. The church women were there in their good holokū. The poi man was there, and the fish woman. The men from the saloon were there too, standing back by the road with their hands in their pockets, because forty dollars is forty dollars and they wanted to see it lost or won with their own eyes.

Kumu was sitting on a mat on her floor with the doors open and a lamp beside her, the way she sat to hear children read. Kimo took off his hat at the door. He came in and knelt down on the mat in front of her, a big man in a ruined silk shirt with the King's cross hanging off him, and touched his forehead to her hand.

Kumu, he said. *Something has happened to me. You know what it is. I came because I know you can put it out. Be a shelter for me.*

You came to the right house, said Kumu.

She looked at him for a long time.

How many times have you cried for her, Kimo?

He did not understand. *I only knew her seven days.*

You cried for her when you were two years old, said Kumu, *in the measles year, when they carried your mother out of the house in a mat. I was there. You cried for her when you were fourteen and that girl from Mānoa married the Portuguese. You cried for her in Kona when your wife died having the baby, and you cried for the baby. You cried for her every time.* She did not raise her voice. *It is always the same girl, Kimo. You have been crying for her since before you could walk. Put all of it together, everything you ever cried, and it is more water than the ocean around these islands.*

He was crying now. He did not wipe it.

She put her hand on his head, on his wet hair, the way she had put it there when he was nine and could not get past the long words in the third primer, and said a verse to him in Hawaiian, out of the Book, very quietly, so that the people at the door had to lean in.

> *Remember ye not the former things, neither consider the things of old.*
>
> *— Isaiah 43:18*

That's all, she said. *Don't hold on to what's gone. Don't reach for what hasn't come. And what's in your hands right now, let go of that too. Then you'll be at peace.*

The people at the door said afterward that nothing happened. Kimo knelt there with her hand on his head. The lamp burned. Out past the grove the surf went on. And then they saw his face change, the way the face of a child changes when the long word finally comes apart into its sounds and he can read it, and after that it did not change back.

He sat back on his heels. He looked around the little room as if he had never been in it, though he had been in it every day for four years of his childhood. He looked at the lamp. He looked at his own hands. He did

not look sad, and he did not look happy, and the fish woman, who was nearest the door, said later that he looked like water when the wind stops.

Kumu, he said, after a while. *It's finished. There's nothing more I have to do. Let me go now.*

She knew what he meant. So did everybody at the door, and one of the church women began to cry.

Not yet, said Kumu. *All these people came out tonight in the dark to see. Some of them came to see me made a liar of. Tell them first. Tell them what you did with your life, that brought you here.* Then she said, *But don't tell it standing on my floor.*

Kimo understood. He unlooped the rawhide quirt from his wrist, where it had been for twenty years, and laid it down on the mat in front of her, very carefully, the way you put down something that belongs to somebody else.

Then he rose into the air.

V. Sandalwood

The coconut grove at Kālia · the same night

HE WENT UP SLOWLY, THE WAY SMOKE GOES UP WHEN THERE IS no wind. He went out through the open doors with his knees still bent as if he were kneeling, and up past the eaves of the schoolroom to the height of one coconut palm, and stayed there, with the lanterns shining up on the soles of his boots. Then he came down again, and set his feet on Kumu's steps, and bent and pressed his nose to hers, and breathed, the old greeting.

Then he went up again. He went up past one palm, and two, and three, and the lanterns were swinging all over the yard because the people holding them were shaking, and four, and five, and six, and seven, until he was as high above the grove as seven coconut trees standing one on another. There he crossed his legs and sat, the way a man sits on a mat to talk, with the lei on his hat and the King's cross on his chest, against the stars over Lēʻahi. The saloon men took their hands out of their pockets.

His voice came down as clear as if he were sitting in the yard.

Listen, he said. *This is what I did.*

When I was twelve years old and could read, I sat in that schoolroom and thought: what work is there that takes away people's trouble? And I watched the ones who went around the island with the Book, and I thought, that is the work. So I took Kumu's primers in a sack and I went around Oʻahu on my two feet. Kāneʻohe. Kahuku. Waialua. Waiʻanae. I stopped at every house and said, come and learn to read, come to church, there is nothing in the world as good as this. I said it at every gate.

There was an old chiefess at Waialua. She heard me at her gate and called me in and said, what are you about, boy, going around like this? I told her. She said, how do you travel? I said, on my feet. She said, that won't do, and she took a lei off her own neck and put it on mine, white flowers strung so close together they looked like a strand of pearls, and she gave me a horse.

So I went around on the horse saying the same thing. The next year she called me in again and asked the same question, and I said the same thing, and she said, a horse is not enough, and gave me a buggy and two horses to pull it. The year after that she asked again, and I said again, and she gave me land at Waialua, and money, and a black suit, and a gold watch. And I wore all of it, and went around in the buggy in the black suit, saying the same thing, for years. People said I smelled of sandalwood when I came into a house. I never knew why. There had been no sandalwood in these mountains since my grandfather's time. The chiefs had sent all of it to China.

Then she died, and I went to Hawaiʻi and rode cattle, and I forgot. That's all. That's what I did.

Everyone in the yard said afterward that while he was telling it they could smell it, faint, the dry sweet smell of the sandalwood that old women used to beat into their kapa when they were young, and that some of them had not smelled it in forty years and began to cry at it before they knew what it was.

Then he stopped talking. He sat up there and looked for a long while at the lamp in Kumu's open door, the small yellow flame of it, the way a man looks at a road he is about to take. And then he was burning.

It was not like a house burning. There was no smoke and no sound. A light came out of him all at once, from inside, the clear white-gold of a kukui-nut torch, and stood around him in the air in the shape of a man sitting, and went up, and was gone. The people in the yard put their hands over their eyes. When they took them away there was nothing in the sky over the grove but the stars.

Then something began to come down.

It came down slowly, turning, small and white, the way the blossoms come down off a kukui tree in the wind. Kumu had come out onto her steps. She sent Ioane running for a clean bed sheet, and when he brought it she took two corners and gave him the other two, and they held it out between them under the grove, an old woman and a boy, and the white things came down into it. They lay on the sheet like flowers. They were not flowers. Nobody ever agreed afterward about what they were. Last of all, turning over and over, the King's gold cross came down on its ribbon and landed in the middle of the sheet with a small sound, the enamel not even cracked, and lay face down, so that the word on the back of it was what showed.

Kumu folded the sheet. She did not say anything. The saloonkeeper went back to the bar that night and paid out forty dollars and closed his doors.

• • •

She buried what was in the sheet the next morning where the Waikīkī road crossed the lane that went up to Mōʻiliʻili, on the corner, under a flat stone from the beach. She said it should be where the roads met, so that people going any direction would pass it. Kēhau was buried at Kawaihaʻo the same day, and the Puna troupe danced for the King at the great lūʻau without her.

The quirt stayed on the mat in Kumu's front room for the rest of her life. Nobody picked it up.

VI. What to Call Him

Kawaiaha'o · December 1886

The deacons at Kawaiahaʻo argued about it into the new year. They argued on the steps after the morning service and in the yard after the afternoon one, under the big trees, in their black coats, and the women listened from the shade.

Some of them said he was a saint, and you could see it was so, because nobody else in the history of the kingdom had gone up like that, not even the old kings. Others said he was a chief, a true one at last, the King had as much as made him one. And some said it was a scandal to call him either. He had been drunk for seven days. He had died in a silk shirt with three lei on his hat and champagne in his blood and a dancing girl's death on him, wearing the King's gold, at the height of a jubilee the opposition papers had been complaining about all month. Three years before, the printers of the coronation hula program had been hauled into court for obscenity. A man could not be a saint in a hat like that.

In the end two of the old deacons walked out to Kālia to ask Kumu, because she had been there, and because she had taught both of them their letters.

She was in the schoolroom. It was afternoon, and the children had gone, and she was cleaning slates with a rag and a bowl of water. She listened to the whole argument without stopping. Then she wrung out the rag.

You've been looking at his hat, she said.

> *But the LORD said unto Samuel, Look not on his countenance, or on the height of his stature; because I have refused him: for the LORD seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.*
>
> *— 1 Samuel 16:7*

He was quiet at the end, she said. *He wasn't grabbing at anything. He put the whip down in front of everybody, and he never picked anything up again, not against a man or a horse or anything that lives. He went to the people at Kona*

with the law in one hand and the quirt in the other and he brought peace down that mountain, and then he came here and put down the quirt. Call him a saint. Call him a chief. Both are right. You want to know what the Lord calls him, it's in Matthew.

> *Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.*
>
> *— Matthew 5:9*

The deacons stood a while. Then one of them asked if she wanted help with the slates, and she gave him a rag.

• • •

Kumu Lahela died in 1893, in the spring, a few months after the Queen was put off her throne, and they buried her at Kawaiahaʻo near the Puna girl. The schoolroom at Kālia came down a few years after that. The fishponds were filled in, and the rice fields, and the Waikīkī road was paved, and given a king's name, and lined with hotels.

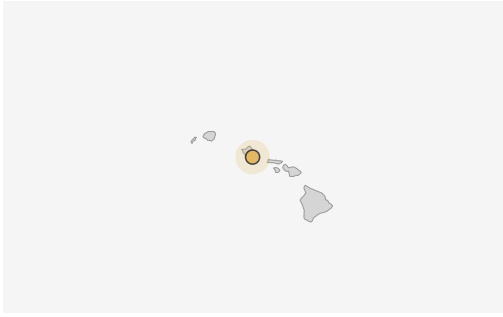
But the flat stone stayed on its corner a long time, where the roads met. People going by on foot would stop and take off a lei and lay it there, maile and ʻilima and white flowers, and the old women told the children what was under it, and the children did not believe them. In the windy months the kukui trees dropped their blossoms on it, small and white, and the blossoms lay on the stone among the lei, and you could not have said which of them had come down from where.

Background

The verse

> *He who, though dressed in fine apparel, exercises tranquillity, is quiet, subdued, restrained, chaste, and has ceased to find fault with all other beings, he indeed is a Brahmana, an ascetic (sramana), a friar (bhikshu).*
>
> Dhammapada 142, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi rewards his minister Santati for putting down a frontier revolt by giving him the kingdom for seven days and a dancing girl. Drunk on the seventh day and riding the state elephant in all his ornaments, Santati nods to the Buddha without getting down, and the Buddha smiles and says that Santati will come to him that very day, awaken at a four-line verse, and pass away seated in the air. Skeptics wait to catch the Buddha in a lie. That afternoon the dancer, who had fasted for a week to dance more gracefully, collapses and dies in the middle of her dance, and Santati's drunkenness vanishes "like a drop of water on a red-hot potsherd." The Buddha tells him he has wept for her more tears than the four oceans hold, and teaches him to let the past dry up, want nothing from the future and grasp nothing now. Santati awakens, asks leave to die, and at the Buddha's request rises seven palm trees high to tell his past good deed: in a former life he went about on foot praising the Buddha, the Dharma and the Sangha, and a king gave him a garland like a string of pearls, then a horse, a chariot and an elephant, and his body smelled of sandalwood. Then he passes away in fire, and his relics fall like jasmine flowers into a white cloth the Buddha holds out, and are enshrined at a crossroads. When the monks ask whether a man who died in finery may be called a monk or a brahmin, the Buddha says he is both. Read the full commentary story.



Honolulu, Kingdom of Hawai'i

Honolulu, 1886

King Kalākaua turned fifty on November 16, 1886, and the kingdom marked it with a two-week jubilee that ran from November 15 to 29. The police force paid tribute at ʻIolani Palace at sunrise on the birthday; rockets went up from Punchbowl; there was a firemen's parade, a regatta, a ball, a state dinner and a lūʻau. The palace had been lit by electricity that July, the first electric lights in the kingdom. The legislature appropriated $15,000 for the jubilee, and the final cost was later reported at $75,000. As at his 1883 coronation, the King had the hula performed openly on the palace grounds. It had been forbidden by law under the Christian convert Kaʻahumanu and kept out of public life for decades after, and many Christian Hawaiians and much of the foreign press still condemned it; after the coronation, two Honolulu publishers

were convicted of obscenity for printing the Hawaiian words of some of the coronation hula. Kalākaua had founded the Royal Order of Kalākaua in 1874; its badge carries the word *KEOLA*, "eternal life," on the reverse.

Hawai'i's sandalwood was cut for the China trade from 1791 until about 1840, peaking between 1815 and 1826, until no large trees were left; Hawaiians had once beaten the powdered heartwood into kapa cloth as a perfume. In 1886 the road from Honolulu to Waikīkī ran through fishponds, taro patches and rice fields worked by Chinese farmers. It was renamed Kalākaua Avenue in 1905, and the wetlands around it were drained after the Ala Wai Canal was dug in the 1920s. Seven years after the jubilee, in January 1893, Kalākaua's sister and successor, Queen Lili'uokalani, was overthrown.

After the story of the minister Santati from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 142). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.10

The Sugar Sack

> *Do not become like the horse and the mule, who have no understanding.*
> *— Psalm 31:9 (Douay-Rheims)*

Así me lo contaron, along the North Platte.

I. The Pail

Scottsbluff, Nebraska · September 1933

Jesús Ortega was eighteen years old in the fall of 1933, the third dry year running, and he owned a shirt, a pair of pants with no seat to speak of, a beet knife, and a lard pail. The shirt his mother had sewn for him in 1931 out of two cotton sacks from the Great Western sugar factory, and if you stood behind him you could still read most of the word WESTERN across his shoulders, faded to the color of weak coffee, and a piece of the word GRANULATED down the left side. The lard pail had held lard once. Now it held whatever people put in it.

His family had gone back to Mexico in the spring of 1932, on a train out of Scottsbluff with forty other families, because there was no work, and men from the relief had come around to say there would be nothing more for people like them, and that the tickets would be paid. Jesús had been born in a beet shanty outside Minatare. He had never seen Mexico. Somewhere east of North Platte, in the night, while his mother slept against the window with his little sisters across her lap, he had gotten up and walked to the end of the car and stepped off the back of the train onto the ballast and stood there in the dark and watched the red light go away.

He had been on the road a year and a half since. He thinned beets in June with the short hoe, bent double, and topped them in October with the hook knife, and in between and after he rode the freights to Cheyenne and Denver and back, and slept in the jungles by the tracks with the other boys and the old men, and walked up to back doors with his lard pail and his hat in his hand. He was good at back doors. He knew which ones. He knew to say ma'am and to say it once.

Ramón Archuleta saw him at the back door of the Lincoln Café on a Saturday at the end of September, holding out the pail.

Ramón was twenty-four and had grown up four shanties down from the Ortegas, and he was home on leave from the Civilian Conservation Corps in a pair of Army shoes so shined you could have combed your hair in them. He had gone into the C's in the spring, in the first enrollment, and he was an assistant leader already, which meant six dollars more a month and a stripe, and he had put on so much weight that Jesús did not know him at first, and then did.

Ramón looked at the shirt and the pail and the pants for a long time.

Chuy, he said. *Wouldn't the C's be better than this?*

Who's going to take me in the C's? Look at me.

I'll take you, said Ramón.

He took him home to his mother's house on the south side, past the sugar factory, and his mother heated water on the stove and filled the washtub on the kitchen floor and went out to sit on the step. Ramón bathed him himself, with a bar of yellow soap and a scrub brush and a quart of kerosene for the lice, the way you would wash down a horse that had come in off the range, and Jesús stood in the tub with his ribs showing and let him. On Monday Ramón walked him to the county relief office and stood behind him in the line and told the woman at the desk that Jesús Ortega was a citizen of the United States born in Scotts Bluff County, that he was single and unemployed and willing, and that his aunt, Rosario Ortega, a widow on relief on the south side, would be glad of twenty-five dollars a month. All of it was true. The woman wrote it down.

The enrollment was in October. Jesús went up in the back of an Army truck with eleven other boys from the valley, north, a hundred miles, into the Pine Ridge country.

II. The Cottonwood

Fort Robinson, Nebraska · October 1933

Fort Robinson lay under the white bluffs at the edge of the pines, a city of red brick barracks and stables and parade ground along Soldier Creek, and in every pasture for miles, in every direction, there were horses. Since the war the Army had made it the largest remount depot in the world. Horses came in by the trainload from the ranches to be broken and schooled and shipped out to the cavalry, and mules for the pack trains and the artillery, thousands of them, bays and sorrels and blacks and greys, and at evening when they were driven in to water you could hear them coming before you saw them, like weather.

The CCC company had a row of the old barracks at the end of the post. The boys planted pine seedlings on the burned slopes of the ridge and built check dams in the gullies and strung fence, and the Army officers who ran the camp ran it like the Army, with reveille at six and inspection on Saturday, and the boys complained about it, and ate.

At the supply room they took his name and his measurements and gave him two of everything. Two suits of wool underwear. Two olive drab shirts and two pairs of olive drab breeches left over from the war in France, smelling of mothballs. Two suits of blue denim for work. A mackinaw. A wool cap. Two pairs of Army shoes, and socks, and a toothbrush and a razor and a comb. He had never in his life owned two of anything.

He put it all on at once in the barracks and stood with the sugar-sack shirt in one hand and the lard pail in the other, and did not know what to do with them. There was no place for them in the footlocker, which was for issue. He could not put them in the stove. He could not have said why he could not.

He went out the back of the barracks and down the slope to Soldier Creek, where the cottonwoods stood along the water with their leaves gone yellow, and he hung the shirt over a low branch of the nearest one, and hung the pail from a twig beside it by its bail, and left them there, and walked back up the slope in his new shoes.

• • •

The camp had an old man. Every camp did. The rules called them local experienced men, and they were hired to know the country and the work and to keep the city boys from cutting their own feet off with an axe. The old man at Fort Robinson was hired to know mules, because the company worked six teams on the fence lines and nobody else in the camp could get a harness on one without being kicked across the corral.

His name was Achille Dupuy. He was seventy-one. He had been born in St. Martin Parish in Louisiana, before the war, a slave's son, and had gone down to New Orleans at nineteen and enlisted in the Ninth Cavalry, and the Ninth had brought him to Fort Robinson in 1885, and he had ridden out of these same stables a thousand times, and to Cuba and back, and when his enlistments were done he had married a woman in Crawford and stayed. He had worked horses for the remount since there had been a remount. He was a big man gone thin, very straight, very black, with a white mustache, and he went to the six o'clock Mass at the church in Crawford every Sunday with his rosary wound around his fingers, and he spoke so seldom that when he spoke the boys stopped whatever they were doing.

The boys called him Sarge. He had been a sergeant once, and he did not tell them not to.

He looked at Jesús on his first morning at the corral, at the new denim and the new shoes and the hands, which were the hands of a boy who had topped beets.

You know mules?

Some.

Come here then, said Achille Dupuy.

III. Pie

The mess hall · November and December

Breakfast was oatmeal and hotcakes and bacon and coffee with canned milk, and all you could eat of all of it. Dinner was beef and potatoes and gravy and beans and bread and butter, and stewed tomatoes, and on Sundays a pie, cut in six, and there was always somebody who did not want his. Supper was the same as dinner except when it was better. The cooks were boys from the company who had been taught by an Army cook, and their gravy was famous along the Pine Ridge.

The doctor weighed every boy when he came in and again every month. By Thanksgiving Jesús had put on eighteen pounds. By Christmas he had put on twenty-six. His face filled out until he did not know it in the mirror over the washstand. The breeches from France would not button. The supply sergeant issued him the next size, and then the size after that, and wrote it down.

On the first of every month the company clerk sent twenty-five dollars to Rosario Ortega in Scottsbluff, and Jesús got five dollars in his hand, and spent it at the canteen on Bull Durham and candy bars and Coca-Cola.

Days, he worked with the old man. Achille Dupuy did not explain much. He handed Jesús a halter and pointed at a mule, and watched, and when Jesús did it wrong he took the halter back and did it right, slowly, once, and handed it back. He never hit a mule. He carried a whip everywhere, a long one with a braided popper on the end that he said had come with him from the Ninth, and in a month Jesús never once saw him use it. He would only lift it a little, or shift it from one hand to the other, and the mules watched it the way the boys in the barracks watched the lieutenant, and did what he wanted. By December the old man was letting Jesús take a team out to the fence line by himself, a pair of big sorrel mules called Pat and Mike who had put two boys from Omaha in the post hospital, and the other boys stood around at evening to watch him bring them in.

Once, on the fence line, with the wind coming hard off the bluffs and the post-hole digger frozen in the ground, Jesús asked the old man why he had stayed in Nebraska all those years, so far from Louisiana, in the cold. Achille Dupuy thought about it so long that Jesús decided he had not heard.

I came here with a horse, the old man said finally. *Man stays where his horse is.* That was all he said about it, then or ever.

The boys in the barracks started calling him Trapos, Rags, after somebody from the valley told the story of the sugar-sack shirt. He did not mind. They called everybody something.

And somewhere in December, with his belly full and his feet warm and the wind howling down off the bluffs against the brick, he began to be unhappy, and could not have said why that was either.

It was the bugle at six. It was inspection. It was the lieutenant's voice. It was planting pine trees in rows on a hill in the snow and stringing barbed wire across country that had never had a fence on it. It was the freights, which he could hear at night when the wind was right, going down the line toward Crawford with their whistles, the long note and the short. He lay on his cot and listened to them and remembered riding the top of a boxcar across Wyoming in July with the whole sky going by, nobody's anything, his own man. He thought: *What am I doing here? Eating the government's pie in the government's pants. A grown man, fat as a hog, taking charity.*

I'll put my own shirt back on, he thought. *It's still out there. I'll put it on and walk down to the tracks and be done with it.*

IV. The Branch

Soldier Creek · January and February, 1934

He went down after supper on a night in January with the snow squeaking under his shoes. The cottonwoods were bare now, grey against the grey snow, and the shirt was still there over its branch, frozen stiff in the shape of the branch, and the pail hung from its twig with a cap of snow in it.

He took the shirt down. It cracked when he bent it. He held it up in the last of the light and read WESTERN backward through the cloth, and smelled it, and it smelled like the beet fields and the jungles by the tracks and the back doors and his mother's kitchen, all of it at once, and he stood there and talked to himself out loud, the way men on the road learn to do.

Sinvergüenza, he said. *You shameless fool. Look at you. Two pairs of shoes, and you want to throw them in the creek. Three meals a day and pie on Sunday, and you want to go back and hold out a lard pail at the Lincoln Café. Twenty-five dollars a month to your tía, and you want to stop it. Ramón Archuleta washed you in a tub like a horse, and you want to go back to the lice. Go on, then. Put it on. Go knock on doors. Sinvergüenza.*

He said it until he had no more to say, and then he stood there with the shirt in his hands, and something in him that had been loud for a month went quiet. It was like the moment when a mule that has been fighting the harness all morning stops, and stands, and lets out its breath. He hung the shirt back on the branch, frozen side out, and walked back up the slope to the barracks and went to bed and slept.

It lasted nine days. Then the bugle and the lieutenant and the fence lines and the freights in the night, and the government's pie, and he went down to Soldier Creek again, and took the shirt down, and said it all again, out loud, to himself. *Sinvergüenza.* And again it went quiet, and he hung the shirt up and came back.

In February it happened a third time.

The boys in his barracks noticed. A boy does not walk out of a warm barracks after supper in a Nebraska February three times for nothing. On the third night Kenny Albrecht, who had the next cot, a farm boy from up by Hay Springs, caught him going out the back door with his mackinaw on.

Where you going, Trapos?

To see my teacher, said Jesús.

Kenny thought it over. Everybody in the camp knew Jesús spent his days at the corral with old Dupuy, and that the old man had started letting him handle the green mules nobody else would touch. But Dupuy

lived in Crawford and went home at five, and the corral was the other way.

Kenny told the others, and the others decided it was a girl.

V. The Shadow of the Whip

The remount corrals · April 1934

He did not go down to the creek again after that. March went by, and the snow went off the ridge, and the creek ran high and brown with it, and he did not go. He went to the corral every morning with the old man, and to the fence lines, and to the mess hall, and to bed. He slept every night straight through. He did not hear the freights anymore, or if he heard them it was only a train.

The boys noticed that too. One night in April in the barracks Kenny Albrecht asked him, with half the room listening.

Hey, Trapos. You don't go see your teacher anymore?

No.

How come? She throw you over?

The room laughed. Jesús did not. He was sitting on his cot oiling a harness strap across his knees, and he went on oiling it.

When I was tied up, he said, *I had to go to my teacher. I'm not tied up anymore. So I don't have to go.*

Nobody in the room knew what that meant. They decided it meant that he was a liar, or that he thought he was smart, and the next morning three of them went down to the corral before work, because the old man was the only one in the camp whose word they all took, and told him about it. They said Trapos had been sneaking off after dark all winter to see a teacher, and now he said he didn't need a teacher, and wasn't that a lie, and wasn't it a big one.

Achille Dupuy was standing in the middle of the round corral with a long whip in his hand, schooling a remount colt on a line, a four-year-old bay that had come in from a ranch on the Niobrara the week before. He let them talk until they were done. The colt went around him at a trot.

He told you the truth, said the old man.

The boys waited.

When he was tied to something, he went to his teacher, said Achille Dupuy. *Now he's cut the rope himself, and he don't need to go. That's all that is. That's no lie.*

He lifted the whip. He did not crack it. He only lifted it, and the shadow of the lash went out across the dirt in the morning sun in front of the colt, and the colt saw the shadow and moved up into a lope, smooth, and went around the corral like water going around a bowl, and the old man lowered the whip again.

Some horses, he said, *you got to lay it on them every time, and they hate you for it, and they never learn a thing. Some you got to touch, just touch, and they go. And then there's a few, not many, all they got to see is the shadow of it. They see the shadow and they go. They put the whip on themselves.* He looked at the boys from under his hat. *You understand me? I'm not talking about horses.*

Then he said what was in the psalm. He had said it to the boys before, though never all of it at once, and he said it in the voice of a man who had heard it read in a church in Louisiana before any of them were born.

> *Do not become like the horse and the mule, who have no understanding. With bit and bridle bind fast their jaws, who come not near unto thee.*
>
> *— Psalm 31:9*

And then, because they were still standing there with their mouths open, the other thing, from the Epistle, which he had learned in the Ninth from a chaplain, he said, who had made the troopers learn it by heart the way they learned the parts of a saddle.

> *And you, employing all care, minister in your faith, virtue; and in virtue, knowledge; And in knowledge, abstinence; and in abstinence, patience; and in patience, godliness; And in godliness, love of brotherhood; and in love of brotherhood, charity.*
>
> *— 2 Peter 1:5–7*

Go to work, he said, and turned back to the colt.

The three boys went to work. They did not talk about it among themselves, then or later, but Kenny Albrecht wrote a letter home that week, which he had not done since Christmas, and told his mother he was sorry about the thing in the barn, and a boy named Weber who had been drinking canteen beer every night since the fall stopped, and a boy from Omaha who had meant to go over the hill at the end of the month stayed out his enrollment, and signed up for another, and later said he could not have told you why, except that he had seen a horse go around a corral without being hit.

VI. The Nest

Soldier Creek · May 1934

At the end of May, on a Sunday afternoon, Jesús walked down to Soldier Creek for the first time since February, because it was warm and there was nothing to do and the cottonwoods were throwing their cotton, and the whole bottom along the creek was white with it, drifting, like snow that had forgotten which way was down.

The shirt was not on the branch.

The lard pail was there, hanging from its twig by its bail, rusted through at the bottom, full of nothing but light. The shirt was gone. He looked under the tree and along the bank and in the shallows, and did not find it, and he stood under the cottonwood and was surprised to find that it did not matter to him one way or the other.

Then he heard the bird.

It was an oriole, orange and black, scolding him from somewhere overhead, and when he looked up he saw the nest, hanging from the very end of a high thin branch over the water, a little grey pouch swinging in the wind the way orioles make them, woven out of horsehair from the remount pastures and the cotton off the trees and string and grass. And woven all through it, in and out, around and around, were threads of sugar sack, unraveled and pulled out a strand at a time over the winter and carried up and worked in by a beak. On the side of the nest that faced

him, holding the rest of it together, there was one scrap still big enough to read, faded nearly white, and what it said was TERN.

He stood under it a long time with his hat pushed back. The oriole scolded. The nest swung over the water on its branch. Up the slope the bugle blew for supper, and he went.

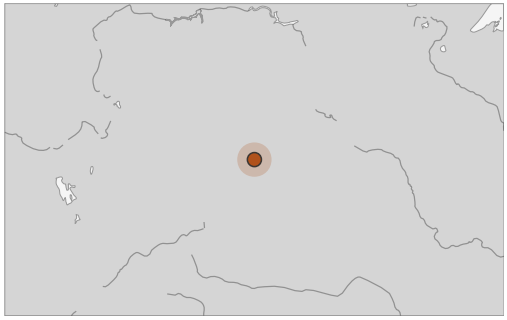
Background

The verses

> *Is there in this world any man so restrained by humility that he does not mind reproof, as a well-trained horse the whip?*
>
> Dhammapada 143, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Like a well-trained horse when touched by the whip, be ye active and lively, and by faith, by virtue, by energy, by meditation, by discernment of the law you will overcome this great pain (of reproof), perfect in knowledge and in behaviour, and never forgetful.*
>
> Dhammapada 144, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha's attendant Ānanda meets a poor youth in a ragged loincloth carrying a begging bowl and asks whether the monk's life would not be better. The youth asks who would ordain him; Ānanda says he will, bathes him with his own hand, and ordains him. Finding no other place for his old rag and bowl, the youth hangs them on the branch of a tree. As a monk he eats well, wears fine robes, grows fat and discontented, and goes back to the tree meaning to put his rags on again; there he scolds himself for a shameless fool, his mind grows calm, and he returns. This happens three times. When the other monks ask where he is going, he says, to my teacher. Later he stops going, and says that while he was bound he went to his teacher, but now the bond is cut. The monks report this to the Buddha as a lie, and the Buddha says that Pilotika ("Rags") has spoken the truth, and gives the verses on the good horse. Read the full commentary story.



Fort Robinson, Nebraska

Fort Robinson and the CCC, 1933-1934

The Civilian Conservation Corps took unemployed, unmarried young men, usually from families on relief, and gave them food, clothing, shelter and thirty dollars a month, twenty-five of which was sent home. The camps were run by Army officers, and older "local experienced men" were hired to teach the work and look after the boys. Enrollment records sorted men as white or Black only, so no one counted the Mexican Americans who served. In western Nebraska, many of them came out of the sugar-beet country around Scottsbluff, where Great Western Sugar had opened a refinery in 1910 and Mexican families worked the fields. In the Depression many of those families left for Mexico, part of the Mexican Repatriation in which a large share of those who went were American-born children.

Fort Robinson, near Crawford in the Pine Ridge country of northwest Nebraska, was the headquarters of the Ninth Cavalry from 1887 to 1898. The regiment had been organized in New Orleans in 1866 with men from Louisiana and Kentucky, and it fought at Kettle Hill and San Juan Hill in 1898. In 1919 the fort became a quartermaster remount depot, eventually the largest in the world, where horses and mules were received, schooled and issued to the Army. From 1933 to 1935 the post also served as a CCC camp, district headquarters and hospital center.

After the story of Pilotika from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 143 and 144). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

10.11

The Long Day

> *The king's heart is in the hand of Jehovah as the watercourses:*
> *He turneth it whithersoever he will.*
> *— Proverbs 21:1*

This is the way they tell it, at Sacaton.

I. The Window

Phoenix and the Gila villages · the years of famine

THE GRANDMOTHERS BEGAN IT THE SAME WAY EVERY TIME, SO that the children knew where they were.

In the dry years, when the settlers at Florence had taken the river into their big canal and there was nothing left in the Gila but stones and tamarisk, the men of the villages cut mesquite. They cut it along the old fields that had no water any more, and stacked it by the railroad at Sacaton Station in cords as high as a house, and hauled it to Phoenix in wagons to sell for stove wood, and the money bought flour. It was the only work there was. Some years the people ate the government's flour, which had worms in it, and the government's bacon, which was green. Boys grew up who had never seen wheat standing in a field in their own village, though their grandfathers had sold wheat to the soldiers and the stage line and the whole Territory of Arizona.

Luis Manuel was one of the woodcutters. He was from Blackwater. In the winter of 1897 he hauled a load to Phoenix the week before Christmas and slept in a friend's yard on Jefferson Street to save the price of a camp, and on the Saturday night the friend said, *Come, you have to see the rich man eat.*

There was a man in Phoenix who owned a hotel on Washington Street, and a bank, and part of a canal company, and every Christmas he had his dinner set out in the big front window of the hotel dining room with the curtains open, so the town could see it. It was in the newspaper. A band played on the sidewalk. People came from all over the valley and stood in the street in the cold, Mexicans and Chinese and soldiers and cowboys and Pima woodcutters, and watched him eat. Roast turkey. Oysters that had come on ice on the train. Ham, and white bread, and potatoes with butter, and cakes, and oranges, which Luis had never tasted, piled up in a silver dish.

The smell of it came out through the door every time a waiter opened it. Luis had eaten one tortilla since morning. He stood in the street and smelled the turkey, and something happened in him that the grandmothers always described with their hands flat against their stomachs. He said, *I want that plate. If I don't get that plate I'll die.*

His friend laughed at him. But Luis kept saying it, and at last the friend, who had been to the mission school and was not afraid of white men, pushed to the front of the crowd and called through the glass three times, louder each time, until the rich man put down his fork.

There's a man here from the reservation who wants your dinner. He says he'll die without it.

Every plate on this table cost me more than his whole wagon, the rich man said, and the crowd laughed. *If I fed everybody who wanted it, what would I eat?* But he was enjoying himself, and he looked at Luis a long time through the window, and said: *Tell you what. Haul wood for my hotel for three years. Three years, every week, and at the end of it you can sit right here in my chair and have my Christmas dinner.*

Luis went home to Blackwater and told his wife. Then he hauled wood to that hotel for three years, every week, through two summers when the thermometer on the hotel porch said a hundred and fifteen, and never once was his cord short or his wood green. And on Christmas Eve of 1900 the rich man, who was a man of his word whatever else, had the band out on the sidewalk and the newspaper man there and the curtains open, and Luis Manuel sat in the big chair in the window in a borrowed collar with

the whole dinner in front of him. The turkey. The oysters. The oranges in the silver dish.

He had his fork in his hand when the thin old man came to the door.

Nobody saw where he came from. The grandmothers said he came out of the dark the way a coyote comes, already there. He was an O'odham man, very old, very thin, with a flour sack over his shoulder and dust to the knee, and he stood just inside the dining room door with nothing in his hands, and waited.

Luis looked at him. He looked at the plate. He thought: I have worked three years for one dinner because I never in my life gave anything away. This will feed me one night.

He got up out of the rich man's chair with the plate in both hands and walked across the dining room and began to put the food into the old man's flour sack. When it was half gone the old man put his hand over the mouth of the sack. Luis moved his hand away. *Grandfather, one plate doesn't cut in two,* he said. *Take it all.* And he put in the rest of it, the oranges last.

The old man looked at him and said something in O'odham that the grandmothers would not repeat, because they said it belonged to Luis and nobody else. Then he went out the door with the sack, and down Washington Street to the west, toward the Estrella mountains, and the whole crowd in the street turned and watched him walk until they could not see him. That same night, people said afterward, every house at Komatke under the Estrellas had meat, and white bread, and nobody could ever say where it came from, and nobody asked. Some things you don't ask.

When the rich man heard the shouting in the street he thought they were laughing at the Indian, and sent a waiter out to see. The waiter came back and told him. The rich man sat a long time in the empty window. Then he sent for Luis and gave him a team of mules and a new wagon and two hundred dollars in gold, and said, *I have eaten in this window for eleven years and I never once gave anybody anything.* They were friends after that, the grandmothers said. Luis Manuel bought seed wheat with the gold. He was the great-grandfather.

II. The Longing

Sacaton · 1921–1922

His granddaughter Ruth married a man from Sacaton who farmed twenty acres of allotment land on the government ditch, and in the fall of 1921, when she knew she was carrying a child, a longing came on her that she could not explain to anybody.

She wanted to feed the church. All of it. Elder Simon and the other elders and the minister and the women's society and every family that came in wagons to the Sacaton meetinghouse on a Sunday, two hundred people, more. She wanted to cook for them herself, a whole day's cooking, and serve them, and then sit down at the very end with the old women behind the cook fires and eat whatever was left in the bottoms of the pots.

Her husband told her she was crazy. The flour alone would cost forty dollars. Her mother told her pregnant women got notions. But the longing would not go away, and in the end the family gave it to her, because a longing like that in a woman carrying a child is not a thing you refuse. At the Thanksgiving meeting she and her sisters and aunts cooked over six fires behind the adobe meetinghouse from four in the morning. Beef stew with chili. Tepary beans. Squash. Tortillas as big as a wagon wheel, a hundred of them, two hundred. Pinole to drink. Coffee boiled in washtubs with a sack of sugar in it. Ruth served Elder Simon first, because he was the oldest of the elders, and the whole church after him, and at dark she sat down with the old women on a log behind the fires and ate cold beans out of the bottom of the big pot with a tortilla, and she said it was the best meal of her life.

The boy was born in July. From the day they knew he was coming, Ruth said, nobody in that house had been sick. Not a fever, not a cut that went bad. Her husband's mother, who had coughed for nine years, stopped coughing. So when Elder Simon came to the house to pray over the baby, and asked what they would call him, Ruth said, *His name is Joseph. But we call him Happy.* Elder Simon laughed and put his old hand on the baby's head and said, *Happy. Good.*

Ruth said one more thing that day, to her husband, quietly. *Whatever he wants to do, when he's big enough to want things, I won't stand in front of him.*

III. Water, Arrows, Wheels

Sacaton · June 1930

That spring Mr. Coolidge, who had been President, came out to the new concrete dam up in the canyon at San Carlos and made a speech on it, and the newspapers said the water was coming back to the Pima at last. Some of the old men went up to see it. The lake behind the dam was dry. There was grass growing in it, and they said a man from Oklahoma who made jokes on the radio had looked at it and said if it were his lake he would mow it. The old men came home and did not say much. The fields at Sacaton that June were watered from the government pumps, a little, when the pumps were running, and the wheat was thin.

Happy was seven. In May he had said to his mother, *I want to go live with Elder Simon.*

Elder Simon was seventy-four that year. He had been an elder of the Sacaton church since before there was an adobe church to be an elder of, and before that, when he was young, he had been the canal boss of his village in the last good years, the man who decided who got water and when, and walked the ditches with a shovel on his shoulder before dawn. He lived alone now in a two-room adobe near the meetinghouse, with a ramada in front and one peach tree that he watered from a bucket. His sister lived in the brush house across the yard. Her name was Juana, and she had been blind since she was a girl, and she sat in the shade by the gate of the yard most of every day, shelling beans by feel, and knew who was coming down the road before the dogs did.

Ruth did not stand in front of him. She went to Elder Simon after church and asked, and he said yes. Then she did it properly. She bought Happy new overalls and a white shirt and shoes at the trading post, and the whole family drove him over in two wagons on a Sunday afternoon with the children riding on top of the bedrolls, and handed him over at the gate.

Elder Simon looked down at him. *It is hard, living with an old man. Getting up in the dark. Praying a long time. Nobody to play with. You think you'll like it?*

I'll do what you tell me, Happy said.

For seven days the family brought food to the church at noon, and on the eighth day Elder Simon said, *Today you carry my things,* and they set out walking toward the agency. Happy carried the old man's Bible, and his hat when the old man wanted his hands free, and a lard bucket with water in it.

They came first to a field where two men were irrigating. One stood at the head of the ditch with a shovel and cut the bank, and the water came through, brown and slow, and the other man walked ahead of it down the furrows, opening a little dam here with his foot, closing another with a shovelful of mud, and the water turned where he turned it and went where he wanted it to go, row after row, to the end of the field.

What are they doing?

Leading the water.

Does the water want to go there?

Water doesn't want anything. It goes downhill. They show it which downhill.

They came next to a ramada where an old man sat over a little bed of mesquite coals with a pile of arrow shafts beside him, arrowweed, for the boys who hunted rabbits along the dry river. He took a shaft and warmed it over the coals and bent it in a grooved stone and held it up to his eye and sighted down it, and bent it again, and sighted, until it was straight as a sunbeam, and laid it aside and took another.

Does the stick know it's being made straight?

A stick doesn't know anything.

They came last to the agency shops at Sacaton, where in the shade of the big wagon shed two Pima men and a white blacksmith were putting an iron tire on a wagon wheel. The tire had been in the fire till it glowed, and they carried it with tongs, three of them, and dropped it over the wooden rim, and hammered it down all the way around while the wood smoked, and then poured water on it so it shrank tight with a sound like

a man breathing in. The wheel had been boards and spokes and a hub, things that would not go anywhere by themselves. Now it was a wheel.

Does the wood want to be a wheel?

No.

Happy stood in the shade a long time with the old man's Bible against his chest, looking at the wheel, and Elder Simon let him.

Then the boy said, *Grandfather, take your Bible. And your hat. I want to go back.*

The old man did not argue with him, and he did not think, as an old man might, this child has been with me eight days and is giving me orders. He took the Bible and the hat. *All right. Go.*

Happy started back up the road, and stopped, and turned around.

Grandfather. When you bring me something to eat, bring me the good food. All of it. Every good thing there is.

And where am I going to find every good thing there is, in this country, in June?

If you can't find it by your luck, Happy said, *find it by mine.*

Elder Simon took the key to his house off the string around his neck and gave it to him, and went on toward the agency alone.

IV. The Long Morning

Elder Simon's house · the same day

HAPPY LET HIMSELF INTO THE OLD MAN'S HOUSE AND SHUT the door and pulled the latch string in, and sat down on the dirt floor in the cool dark with his back against the adobe wall and his new shoes in front of him.

Nobody knows what he did in there. He was seven. He said afterward only that he thought about the water, and the stick, and the wheel, and about how they could not do anything for themselves and still a man could make them go right, and that if a man could do that to a ditch and a stick and a piece of wood that did not know anything, then a person who did know something ought to be able to do it to himself. And he sat there, and did it.

What other people saw, they told for years.

They said that all that morning no bird made a sound anywhere near Elder Simon's yard. The grackles that always quarreled in the cottonwoods by the meetinghouse sat in the branches with their beaks shut. The roosters at the agency did not crow. A woman hanging wash said the doves came down to the ditch to drink, as they always did, and stood on the bank, and did not drink, and flew away again without a sound. Four old men from four different villages, who did not know each other well, each said afterward that they had been on the road that morning, one on each side of Elder Simon's place, north and south and east and west, and each had felt that he should not go any nearer, and had stood a long time in the road, and had turned around and gone home.

They said that a man in a black hat, whom nobody knew, stood beside Elder Simon's door all morning with his hand on the latch string, and that when Juana's grandson came across the yard to get a hoe out of the ramada, the man looked at him, and the grandson forgot the hoe.

And they said the sun stopped. It was nearly the longest day of the year anyway. But the agency clerk, who kept a log of the readings on the thermometer at the agency office, noticed at what he thought was half past ten that the shadow of the water tank lay across the agency yard exactly where it had lain when he came out at nine, and he looked at it a long time and thought he had sunstroke and went inside and lay down. The trader at the post said his clock stopped, and started again later on its own, and he never had to set it.

Juana sat by the gate in the shade with her pan of beans. She did not shell any. She sat with her hands still in the pan and her face turned toward the house, the way blind people turn toward a sound, though there was no sound.

V. Every Good Thing

The Allen place, by the agency · noon

Elder Simon stood in the road outside the agency with the Bible under his arm and thought: where? Every family he knew was

EATING GOVERNMENT FLOUR AND PUMP-WATER SQUASH. AND then, the way you remember where you put something, he thought of the Allens.

Daniel Allen had one of the few fields near Sacaton that had kept its own well, and his wife had come from Salt River, where there was still water in the canals, and her family had sent her a wagonload of things that very week. When Elder Simon came to their gate at noon, the whole family came out, and Mrs. Allen said, *Elder! It's good you came today of all days,* and they took his Bible and his hat and sat him in the best chair under the ramada and brought him a cup of water from the well and coffee with sugar.

Then they asked him to talk to them about the Word until the food was ready, and he did, sitting in the shade with their children at his feet, until he smelled that it was time and stopped.

The food came. Beef and chili. Tepary beans, the brown and the white. Tortillas off the griddle, thin as paper. Squash with green corn. Cholla buds that Mrs. Allen's mother had picked and dried in April. Watermelon from Salt River. Peaches. A jar of syrup from the saguaro fruit, dark as molasses. Fried bread with sugar on it. A sweet pudding of roasted wheat. Coffee again. He had not seen a table like it since he was a young man.

He told them about the boy and asked if he could take the food to him. Mrs. Allen would not hear of it. *You eat first, Elder. Eat all of it. Then we'll fill a bucket for the boy.* And they would not let him leave until he had eaten, so he ate, and then Mrs. Allen filled a lard bucket with some of everything and pressed the lid down on it and tied it with a cloth, and Elder Simon thanked them and set out for home at a pace that made the Allen children laugh, an old man of seventy-four half running down the agency road with a lard bucket, thinking, the boy must be hungry. The boy has been alone since morning. The boy is seven.

VI. The Gate

Elder Simon's yard · afternoon

Juana was standing at the gate when he came. She had never stood at the gate in her life. She had one hand on the gatepost, and her blind face turned toward him on the road, and he slowed down, and stopped.

Sister. Let me in. I have food for the boy.

What is it you've got?

He did not understand why she asked, but he answered her, because she was his elder sister and he had answered her all his life. *Food.*

And what is food for?

For when you're hungry. So you feel good.

And what does feeling good do?

He thought about it. *It fills a person out. Puts color in them. Makes them look well.*

And then what?

Elder Simon stood in the road with the bucket and thought about the famine years, and the green bacon, and all the children he had buried, and his own sons hauling wood to Phoenix. *Then they're content,* he said. *Then they lie down in the shade and they're glad to be alive.*

Juana stood listening to something past him, behind him, in the house. Then she took her hand off the gatepost.

All right, she said. *Go on. Give the boy his food.*

The old man went up to his own door. The latch string was pulled in. He knocked, and called, and pushed, and the door gave, and Happy came out into the yard in his white shirt with dirt on the seat of his overalls, blinking in the light, and took the bucket from him with both hands and set it down, and took the old man's hat and fanned him with it.

Eat, said Elder Simon.

Did you eat, Grandfather?

I ate. Mrs. Allen sat on me till I ate. Now you eat.

So the boy sat down on the bench under the ramada and untied the cloth and ate, slowly, a little of everything, like somebody who has all the

time in the world, and when he was done he took the bucket to the ditch and washed it with sand and brought it back and set it upside down on the bench to dry.

And the grackles in the cottonwoods by the meetinghouse all began to talk at once. A rooster crowed at the agency. Juana's grandson remembered the hoe. Down at the agency office the shadow of the water tank swung off across the yard toward the east, and the clerk, coming out on the porch, saw that the sun had gone over the top of the sky while he was not looking, and that it was evening.

VII. Which Downhill

The Sacaton meetinghouse · that night

THE ELDERS MET AT THE MEETINGHOUSE THAT NIGHT, AS THEY did on Wednesdays, and before they prayed they sat on the benches outside in the dark and talked about the day. Everybody had felt it. The morning that would not end, the noon that went on and on, and then the evening coming all at once, as if somebody had let go of it.

The boy only just finished his dinner, one of them said. *At sundown. What kind of day was that?*

Juana had come over on her grandson's arm, which she never did on Wednesdays, and was sitting on the end of the bench with her cane across her knees.

That's what a day is like, she said, *when somebody inside it is working.*

They waited. She did not say much, ever, and they had learned to wait.

This morning that boy saw men leading water in a ditch. He saw an old man straightening arrows over the coals. He saw them putting the iron on a wheel down at the agency. And he went home and shut the door and did it to himself. She turned her face toward where her brother was sitting. *Simon. You were a canal boss. Say it for them. The one in Proverbs about the water.*

Elder Simon said it in O'odham, and then, because the minister was there, he said it in English, the way it was in the big Bible the church had been given by the Presbytery, the new one that said Jehovah. He said the

other one after it, the one from the long Psalm, because it came to him, and his sister nodded.

> *The king's heart is in the hand of Jehovah as the watercourses: He turneth it whithersoever he will.*
>
> *— Proverbs 21:1*
>
> *I thought on my ways, And turned my feet unto thy testimonies.*
>
> *— Psalm 119:59*

Nobody said anything for a while. Somewhere out past the agency the government pump started up, thudding, and they could hear the water it lifted begin to run in the ditch along the road, not much of it, a little, enough.

• • •

Happy lived with Elder Simon until the old man died, in the cold winter of 1937, and walked behind his coffin to the church cemetery with Juana's hand on his shoulder. He went to the Indian school in Phoenix after that, and to the war, and came home, and was an elder himself by the time the water came back down the Gila to Sacaton in his old age, which is another story.

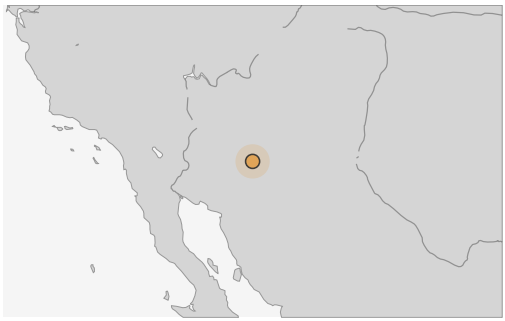
But the grandmothers who tell this one always end it on the evening of the long day, after the elders had gone in to pray. They say the boy took the bucket he had washed and filled it from the ditch, and carried it across the yard to the old man's one peach tree, and knelt, and with his finger drew a little channel in the dust from where he was going to pour it to the foot of the tree. Then he poured. And they say the water ran down his channel and did not go anywhere else. It went where he led it, the whole way, into the dark at the roots.

Background

The verse

> *Well-makers lead the water (wherever they like); fletchers bend the arrow; carpenters bend a log of wood; good people fashion themselves.*
>
> Dhammapada 145, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a poor laborer in an earlier age works three years for a rich man named Gandha, who eats his costly meals on display before the whole city, to earn one bowl of that rice; when the bowl is finally his he gives all of it to a silent holy man, who carries it off through the air and feeds five hundred, and the shamed rich man gives the laborer half his fortune. Reborn in the Buddha's time, he is the son of a woman who longed in pregnancy to feed the elder Sāriputta and all his monks and eat their leftovers. Named Sukha, "Happy," because no one in the house suffered after he was conceived, the boy goes forth at seven. On the eighth day, walking behind Sāriputta, he sees men leading water in channels, fletchers straightening arrows and carpenters shaping wheels, and reasons that if people can master things without minds, he can master his own. He sends the elder on, asking him to bring back food of a hundred flavors, and shuts himself in the elder's cell. The gods silence the birds, guard the door and hold the sun and moon still; Sāriputta is fed by a devoted household and hurries back with a second portion; the Buddha stands at the gate and delays him with four questions about what food produces, until the boy reaches awakening. Then the boy eats, the sun moves, and the monks wonder why the day was so long. Read the full commentary story.



Sacaton, Gila River Indian Reservation, Arizona

The Gila River, 1897–1930

The Akimel O'odham (Pima) and their ancestors farmed the middle Gila with canals for many centuries, and in the 1850s and 1860s they sold wheat to emigrants, the overland mail and the army. Upstream settlers then took the river. The Florence

Canal, finished in 1889, drew off most of what was left; summer crops failed eleven times between 1892 and 1904, and the community's own history calls these the years of famine. To feed their families, men cut mesquite and sold it as stove wood: by 1905 nearly twelve thousand cords a year were going to Phoenix, and in 1901 a newspaper counted more than thirty thousand cords stacked at Sacaton Station waiting for the railroad. The Presbyterian missionary Charles Cook organized the church at Sacaton in 1889, and a larger adobe meetinghouse was built there in 1918.

The Coolidge Dam on the upper Gila, built by the Bureau of Indian Affairs for the San Carlos Irrigation Project, was meant to bring water back to Pima and non-Indian fields alike. Former President Calvin Coolidge dedicated it on March 4, 1930, before the reservoir had begun to fill; Will Rogers, looking at the grass in the dry lake bed, said that if it were his lake he would mow it. The project did not restore Pima farming. In 2004 the Gila River Indian Community won one of the largest tribal water settlements in American history. The verses Elder Simon recites are from the American Standard Version of 1901, which renders the divine name as Jehovah.

After the story of the novice Sukha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 145). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 11

Old Age

II.I

The Oakum Loft

The light broke in upon me by degrees.
— Frederick Douglass, Narrative (1845), chapter VII

This is how the old people told it, on Fells Point.

I. The Bounce

Happy Alley, Fells Point, Baltimore · Christmas 1845

When a young caulker on the Point married, he took his wife to Mother Sewell. A good many of the girls were just up from the Eastern Shore. Some were free and some were hired out by a master in Talbot or Dorchester who had never seen Baltimore, and none of them knew the town. Keziah Sewell did. She owned two houses in Happy Alley, and she washed for the captains' wives on Thames Street and employed six women to help her do it. The husbands went off to the yards at sunup, where a good caulker made a dollar and a half a day, and they knew that whatever their wives did, they did it under her eye. By that Christmas she had some thirty of them. She took them to market and to the meeting on Strawberry Alley, and two nights a week she took them up the outside stair of a chandler's storehouse on Wolfe Street to learn their letters.

In July she also taught them to make cherry bounce. They stoned the sour cherries in her yard and put them down in stone crocks with sugar and spirits, and the crocks stood in her cellar until Christmas. That was for the men. From Christmas Eve to New Year's the yards were shut, and the caulkers of Fells Point kept the holiday the way it was kept from there to Georgia. They drank for a week. The women dipped the bounce and beat the eggs for the nog and carried the cups, and they did not drink in front of their husbands, because that was not allowed them.

On the second of January the mallets started up again along the waterfront. A caulking mallet is live oak, and on a cold morning you could hear forty of them across the Basin. The men went back to work.

There were two crocks left.

We stoned every cherry in there, said Prissy Bordley. So they went to Mother Sewell and asked whether she would walk them out along Harris Creek to the Canton shore, as it was a soft day for January.

Get your work done first, she said.

They got their work done. Then they came with a wash basket between two of them and sheets folded on top of it. Out among the cedars, with Mother Sewell sitting on a stump and looking at the water, they emptied both crocks. They came home down Thames Street in broad day, arm in arm and singing.

She did not raise her voice to them. *Do you know what they say on this Point about colored women who can read? You have just said it for them, the length of Thames Street. That is Tilghman's class, they'll say. You've shamed yourselves and you've shamed me, and your husbands will be home at dark. What do you mean to do?*

We'll say we're sick.

Then you'll be known by your own doing, she said, and she went into her house.

The men came up from the yards with pitch on their hands. *Where is she? Sick.* There was not a man of them who did not know what was left in that cellar and how much of it. Some of those husbands were gentle men and some were not. There was crying that night in Happy Alley and on Strawberry Alley and Wolfe Street, and Mother Sewell sat in her kitchen and listened to it.

II. One Lamp

A storehouse loft on Wolfe Street · Tuesday of Christmas week, 1846

Mr. Nace Tilghman had driven oakum into the seams of ships for forty years. He had bought himself out of it a Sunday at a time, and that took eleven years. When his hands grew too knotted to hold an

IRON HE DID NOT LEAVE THE TRADE. HE RENTED THE LOFT over the chandler's. There he picked old rope apart and rolled the tarred hemp on his knee into the long soft strands the caulkers used, and the yards bought all he could spin. The loft was heaped with it to the rafters. It smelled of Stockholm tar. He kept one whale-oil lamp on a chain from the ridge beam, well clear of everything, and a bucket of sand under it, and he had one rule, which was that nobody moved the lamp.

Twice a week after dark he chalked letters on the wall. He started every scholar on the same four, S and L and F and A, because those were the ones the ship carpenters cut into a timber to say where it went. Starboard, larboard, forward and aft. A woman who had carried her husband's dinner into a yard had seen them all her life. He said there had been a boy on Philpot Street who got his first four letters that way, off the timbers in a yard, with nobody to teach him. That boy had gone North eight years back, and he had lately put his life in a book. The book had come down the Bay in the bottom of a seaman's chest. Mr. Tilghman kept it under the sand in the bucket and read a page from it at the end of each lesson. For a free colored man in Maryland, having that book meant ten to twenty years in the penitentiary. A roomful of colored people at night with no white person among them was something the watch could break up without any book at all.

The next Christmas came. On the Monday of the holiday week the wives went to Mother Sewell and asked to walk out to the shore.

I took you once, she said. *Walk out by yourselves.*

They talked it over among themselves and came back to her. *Then take us up to Mr. Tilghman's tomorrow night, Mother. We want to carry him something for Christmas.*

Now that is fitting, she said. *Get your things ready.*

They came on Tuesday night in their big cloaks with a pound of candles and a paper of sugar and a new slate tied up in a handkerchief. Under the cloaks they had brown jugs. They let her go up ahead of them. On the outside stair in the dark they drank the jugs dry and dropped them one after another into the dock, and then they went in and sat down on the benches in front of him.

Mr. Tilghman, said Mother Sewell, *give these women their lesson.*

He chalked an S on the wall. The front bench was swaying. Somebody laughed and somebody else clapped her hands. Prissy Bordley stood up and began to dance. Then they were all up. They sang a frolic song at the top of their voices and beat the time on the floor with their heels, with the watch house two squares off and the chandler's whole stock underneath them.

The old people always said that it was not only the bounce. They said something had come up the stair behind those women that night and got in amongst them. It wanted that room, and it had been waiting on that stair a long time for somebody to leave the door open.

Prissy's cloak swung out and passed a hand's width under the lamp.

Mr. Tilghman stood at the wall with the chalk in his fingers. He thought that he had not given eleven years of Sundays for himself, and every year since to that loft, to have the thing on the stair walk in and take it.

He looked at the lamp. The flame drew down blue and went out.

There is no dark in a town like the dark in a loft full of oakum. It was the dark of a ship's hold with the hatches on. The singing stopped, and in the quiet every woman there heard what she had been making too much noise to hear. A rattle was going somewhere up Wolfe Street. A man in boots had stopped at the foot of the outside stair. They smelled the tar all around them and remembered what tar does when fire touches it. They thought of the watch house and the penitentiary and the pens on Pratt Street where the Georgia traders bought, and each of them thought of her children. They were so afraid that the liquor dried up inside them. In the space of a few breaths they were cold sober, and no one moved or spoke.

Then there was light at the window. It came from outside and from the west.

The Shot Tower stood across the Falls, most of a mile off. It was two hundred and thirty-four feet of brick, and when it was built nothing in the country stood taller. A man was standing on the rim of it with a lamp in his hand. That is how they told it ever after, the ones who were in the

room. They said the light off that one lamp was as if a thousand moons had come up over Baltimore together. It lay on the Basin and on every mast and yard in it, and on Federal Hill and the roofs of Old Town, and it showed white on the faces at the loft window. Down on Wolfe Street the watchman never lifted his head. They heard his boots go on toward the market.

They heard Mr. Tilghman also. He spoke no louder than he did in class, and they heard him as if he stood at the end of the bench.

What is there to laugh at? Everything in this room will burn, and you dance in it. You're shut up in the dark, every one of you. And you had a lamp here and never looked for it.

Then he read to them. It was the page he had meant to read that night, and he read it from up there.

> *Thus, when the slave asks for virtuous freedom, the cunning slaveholder, knowing his ignorance, cheats him with a dose of vicious dissipation, artfully labelled with the name of liberty.*
>
> *So, when the holidays ended, we staggered up from the filth of our wallowing, took a long breath, and marched to the field,—feeling, upon the whole, rather glad to go, from what our master had deceived us into a belief was freedom, back to the arms of slavery.*
>
> *— Frederick Douglass, Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave (1845), chapter X*

When they turned from the window the loft lamp was burning on its chain as it had been. He was sitting in his chair under it with the book shut on his knee.

III. The Crock

The same night, and after

MOTHER SEWELL SPOKE FIRST. *THAT DRINK IS A WICKED THING, Mr. Tilghman. These are decent women. They sat down in front of you and couldn't keep their own feet under them. Where did such a thing ever start?*

The way I had it, it started with a hunter, he said. *He found a tree with a hollow in the fork. The rain stood in it, and fruit had dropped in and wild grain, and the sun had worked on that all summer. He watched the birds come and drink there. They fell off the limb and lay on the ground a while, and then they got up and flew. So he drank, and he carried some to a holy man who lived by himself in those woods, and the two of them took it to a town in gourds. That town drank until it forgot to plant. It's gone now. They went on to the next town and that one is gone too. At last they brought it to a king. He had the cup at his mouth when a stranger came to the gate with a jar on his hip, crying it like a huckster. Buy my jar! Drink this and you'll fall down your own stair. You'll sleep in the road and tell what you ought to hide, and you'll strike your mother. The king put the cup down and had every pot in the place broken. He's the only king I ever heard of with sense. It is the same pot every time, Keziah. I don't care whose cellar it sits in.*

She went home and carried her crocks up from the cellar one at a time. She did not break them, because a stone crock costs money. She poured what was in them down the gutter of Happy Alley and scalded them with lye. The next July she bought no cherries.

• • •

By spring there was not one of those thirty women who could not read the marks on a timber, and by the next Christmas each of them could read that page for herself. Prissy Bordley read it out to the others on the Tuesday of the holiday week, with her finger under the line, while her husband stood on the outside stair in the cold to keep the door. People said afterward that you could not have got a cup into the hand of one of them.

The biggest crock went up to the loft. It stood by the door for as long as Mr. Tilghman kept school there, filled to the brim with water, with a gourd dipper hung on the rim, under the lamp.

Background

The verse

> *How is there laughter, how is there joy, as this world is always burning? Why do you not seek a light, ye who are surrounded by darkness?*
>
> Dhammapada 146, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred young men of Sāvatthī put their wives in the care of the laywoman Visākhā. After a seven-day drinking festival the women secretly finish the leftover liquor on an outing to a pleasure garden. Visākhā rebukes them, they pretend to be sick, and their husbands beat them. At the next festival she refuses to take them out, so they ask to visit the monastery and carry jugs under their cloaks. Drunk in the hall before the Buddha, and possessed by a spirit of Māra's host, they clap, laugh and dance. He sends out a dark ray that leaves them in blackness and so frightened that the liquor dries up in them. Then he stands on the summit of Mount Sineru and sends out a light like a thousand moons, and speaks the verse. Asked how drink began, he tells the birth story of the pot: a forester finds liquor in the fork of a tree, it ruins city after city, and a king is stopped at the last moment and has the jars broken. Read the full commentary story, or about Visākhā.

Fells Point, Baltimore, Maryland

Fells Point, 1846

The people in this story are invented. Fells Point was Baltimore's shipbuilding district, and the caulking trade there was largely in the hands of Black workers, free and enslaved. Black caulkers named Richard Jones, Henry Scott and John Whittington lived in the 1840s in two small wooden houses on South Wolfe Street that still stand. Frederick Douglass, then Frederick Bailey, grew up partly on Philpot Street and worked as a caulker in the Point's yards until he escaped in September 1838. He wrote that he earned a dollar and a half a day, and that he learned his first letters from the marks ship carpenters cut into timbers: L, S, L. F., S. A. His *Narrative*, pub-

lished in Boston in 1845, describes the week between Christmas and New Year's as a holiday on which slaveholders encouraged drunkenness, and calls it a fraud.

Maryland did not forbid teaching Black people to read, and Black Baltimoreans supported their own schools. But laws passed after 1831 put heavy limits on free Black people, including on meeting for worship without a white person present, and an 1841 law made a free Black person found with abolitionist writing liable to ten to twenty years in prison (see the Pathways to Freedom timeline). The Phoenix Shot Tower, finished in 1828 and a little over 234 feet high, was the tallest structure in the United States when it was built. Oakum is tarred hemp fiber, often picked from old rope, which caulkers drove into a ship's seams with an iron and a mallet. Cherry bounce is an old cordial of sour cherries, sugar and spirits.

After the story of Visākhā's companions from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 146). The original. Text from Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* (1845). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

II.2

What Shall I Cry

> *Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain: the woman that feareth the Lord, she shall be praised.*
> *— Proverbs 31:30*

Así lo oí contar, on the bay below the Castillo.

I. Hot Lard

San Agustín de la Florida · Lent 1736

In the spring of 1736 there were six English ships in the harbor at once, which was against the King's law and everybody knew it, and the men off those ships said that the most beautiful woman between Charles Town and Havana lived in a stone house south of the plaza in San Agustín, and that her name was Gloria.

She was the younger sister of Maestro Pedro Leal, the surgeon of the garrison, who had set half the broken legs in the town and closed most of its knife wounds. Their father had been a soldier and their mother a soldier's widow who took in washing, and when Gloria was fifteen she stopped taking in washing. By twenty-five she owned the stone house, and a woman named Juana who had been bought for her in Havana, and a set of pearls. An English captain had once paid her an onza of gold for a single night, sixteen pieces of eight, and told it all the way up the coast. Officers of the garrison paid her in silver when the situado came from Mexico, and in promises when it did not, which was most years. The town's wives crossed the street when they saw her coming. The town's husbands did not.

That Lent she was living in the house of a merchant's son named Salgado. It was an arrangement. His wife, Doña Inés, was a quiet woman

who went to the friars' church twice a day and kept every fast in the calendar, and who had said to her husband, it was said, that if he must have somebody, let it be somebody she could see, and let it be only until Easter, and let her pray in peace.

Gloria lived in that house for three weeks and could not stand it. She could not stand how quiet Doña Inés was. She could not stand being forgiven before she had done anything. One morning in the kitchen, with the lard spitting in the iron pan for the fish, Doña Inés came in to give an order to the cook and looked at Gloria with no anger at all, and Gloria picked up the pan and threw it.

The cook screamed. The lard went over Doña Inés's face and her neck and her arms, and ran down, and she stood there and wiped her eyes with her sleeve. There was not a mark on her. Not a blister. The cook would swear to it until she died, and so would the kitchen boy, and the lard had been hot enough to fry a mackerel. Doña Inés looked at Gloria for a moment more, and said, *Go home, child, before somebody hurts you,* and went out.

Gloria went home. She did not sleep for two nights. On the third day she found out that the Father Guardian of the Franciscans was to dine at the Salgado house after the noon Mass, and she put on a plain dress and no pearls and went there and knelt on the floor of the dining room in front of everybody and asked Doña Inés to forgive her. She said it to Doña Inés. She looked at the friar.

Fray Lucas Ortega had been born in San Agustín, the son of a sergeant, and except for his years of study in Havana he had never lived anywhere else. He was fifty that year and had a soldier's shoulders and a voice that did not carry far, so that people leaned toward him. He had finished his meal. He put down his spoon.

She forgave you before you came, he said. *You know that. That's what you couldn't stand.*

Be not overcome by evil: but overcome evil by good.

— Romans 12:21

Gloria stayed on her knees a long while after that, and nobody at the table moved, and when she got up the people who were there said that something in her face had gone still, like a pond when the wind drops, and it did not come back. She asked Fray Lucas if he and his friars would eat at her house the next day. He said they would.

They did, and after that they came every day. Eight of them, at noon, in their grey habits, from the friary at the south end of town and from the Christian Indian towns outside the lines where some of them lived. Gloria stood at the door and filled their bowls herself. The situado had not come that year, and the soldiers' families were living on corn and fish and whatever their gardens gave, but there was white bread at Gloria's from English flour off the English ships, and butter, and milk, and eggs, and oranges from her own trees. *Take the butter, Father. Take more milk. Take another loaf for the walk.* What she put in one friar's bowl would have fed three. She spent two pieces of eight a day on it. People said she was buying her way to heaven with smuggled flour. People said a great many things.

What they did not say, because they did not know it, was that the officers had stopped coming. The English captains came to the door that summer as they always had, with their hats in their hands and their silver in their pockets, and Juana sent them away. Gloria went to the friars' church in the mornings and sat at the back, near the door, where Doña Inés sat. The two of them did not speak, in church or out of it. But once in May, coming out into the glare of the plaza after Mass, Doña Inés put her hand for a moment on Gloria's arm, and the women who saw it talked about nothing else for a week.

II. Three Leagues

The coast road north · summer

Fray Bernardo was old and fat and talked, and one day in June, after he had eaten at Gloria's table, he walked three leagues up the coast road to a mission town on the inland water, where a young friar named Gil kept the church for a few dozen Christian families who had

come down from Guale and the islands when the English and their Creek allies burned the old missions, before Gil was born.

Fray Gil was twenty-four and from Galicia and had been in Florida less than a year. He had never been in San Agustín except to land there. He gave Fray Bernardo water from the well and a hammock under the shed, and after the evening prayer the old man lay in the hammock and talked.

Where did you eat today, Father?

At Gloria Leal's.

Is it good there?

Good? Fray Bernardo laughed in the dark. *There's no telling it. White bread. Butter like in Spain. She stands in the door and fills your bowl till it runs over and then she puts in more. One bowl of hers would keep you a week up here. But I'll tell you, as good as the food is, she's better to look at.* And he told it, the way old men tell things, lying in a hammock in the dark with their hands on their bellies. Her hair. Her throat. The way she stood in the door with the light behind her. How the English captain had paid an onza. Fray Gil said nothing at all.

He had never seen her. He would say later that this was the strangest part of it, that it went into him all the same, the way a fever goes into a man who has only walked past the house. He lay on his mat all night listening to the frogs and the old man snoring and could not stop seeing a woman he had never seen.

In the morning he said, carefully, as if it were nothing, that he had business at the friary and would walk back to town with Fray Bernardo, and was there any order to how the eight friars came to her table, and who sat where.

No order, said Fray Bernardo. *First come. Go early, son, and you'll sit at the head, and she'll fill your bowl first.*

Fray Gil did not wait for him. He took his bowl and his staff and started down the coast road alone in the dark before the next dawn, and walked three leagues, and was standing at the door of the stone house south of the plaza with his bowl in his hands when the sun came up out of the sea.

He had come in by the land gate in the Cubo line while it was still grey, past the sentry, who knew a friar when he saw one and did not ask. He had crossed the plaza with the fishermen going down to the boats and the bakers' smoke going up, and the Castillo standing over the bay at the north end of the town, grey stone made of shells, with the first light on it. He had not noticed any of it. He had been walking all night toward a face, and when he got to the door he found that he was afraid to knock, and stood there with the bowl in his hands until Juana opened it to throw out the wash water and nearly threw it on him.

III. The Fever

The stone house · that day

Gloria had fallen sick the afternoon before, just after Fray Bernardo left her door. It began with a headache and a pain in her back, and by night she was burning. She took off her pearls and her rings and her earrings and gave them to Juana to put away, and lay down in her room with the shutters closed.

At noon Juana came in and told her that the friars were at the door, eight of them, and a young one first.

Gloria could not get up. She lay with her eyes closed and gave her orders from the bed. *Let them in. Give them seats in the cool room. Give them the broth first, and bread. When it's time for the rice, fill their bowls, and fill them right, Juana, the way I do it. Don't be stingy because I'm not there to see.*

So Juana and the girl from the Indian town who worked for wages brought the friars in and sat them on the benches and gave them broth and bread and then the rice with milk and cinnamon, and filled their bowls the right way. Then Juana went back to the room.

Carry me out, said Gloria. *I want to greet them.*

Señora, you can't stand.

Then carry me.

So they carried her, Juana under her arms and the girl at her feet, in her shift with a shawl around her, and set her on a stool in the doorway of the cool room. She put her hands together and bowed her head to the fri-

ars. She was shaking all over with the fever. Her hair was down. There was nothing on her, not a ring, not a ribbon.

Fray Gil was at the head of the bench, where he had wanted to be. He looked at her. He thought: if she is like this sick, with nothing on her, shaking, what must she be when she is well, and dressed, and has the pearls on?

That was all. But he could not eat after that. He sat with his bowl in his hands and the rice going cold and heard nothing anybody said. When the other friars rose he rose with them and took his full bowl and walked out of the house and down to the friary at the south end of town, where the masons were laying the first courses of the new stone walls, and went into the cell they had given him in the old wooden building, and put his bowl on the shelf with a cloth over it, and spread his habit on the floor, and lay down on it with his face to the wall.

Another friar came at evening and tried to get him to eat. Fray Gil did not answer him.

Gloria Leal died that night, before the bells for Matins, with her brother holding her wrist.

In the morning Maestro Pedro went up to the Castillo and told the governor, because everyone of any account in the town told the governor such things, and the governor sent his adjutant down to the friary to tell Fray Lucas that the surgeon's sister was dead, she who had fed his friars, and to ask whether she should not be buried in the friars' church, where she had already paid for a grave before the altar of Our Lady.

Fray Lucas was a long time answering.

Don't bury her, he said. *Ask His Excellency for this. Lay her outside the Cubo line, on the open ground, on a bier, where everyone can see. Put a guard on her day and night, so the dogs don't get her, and the buzzards. Don't let anyone touch her. I'll tell him when.*

The adjutant stared at him. Maestro Pedro, when he heard, sat down on the friary steps and put his face in his hands. But he did not ask for anything different, and in the end it was done the way Fray Lucas said.

IV. Four Days

Outside the Cubo line · June 1736

The Cubo line ran from the Castillo across the neck of land to the San Sebastián River, an earth wall faced with palm logs, with a palisade along the top and a ditch in front and the slope planted thick with Spanish bayonet so that no man could climb it without leaving pieces of himself. North of it the soldiers kept the ground cleared for a musket shot, so an enemy would have nowhere to hide. That was where they laid her, on a plank bier on two trestles, in her best dress, with her hands folded and her hair combed by her brother.

The first day she looked asleep. People came out through the gate and stood at a distance and looked at her and went back and said she looked asleep.

The second day the color went out of her. The third day there was a smell that the sea wind took toward the town in the afternoons, and the buzzards came, black ones and red-headed ones, and sat on the palisade in a row and waited, and the two soldiers on guard threw stones at them, and the buzzards moved down a few stakes and sat again. On the fourth day she had swelled. Her face was gone. From her mouth and her nose and her eyes and her ears and the other openings of the body there came the white moving things that come, and her whole body under the good dress was like a cracked pot of boiled rice.

On that day the governor had the drum go through the town.

The crier was Domingo de la Cruz, a free Black man past sixty who had cried every proclamation and every auction in San Agustín for thirty years, the prize cargoes the privateers brought in and the goods of dead men sold in the plaza to pay their debts. Everybody knew his voice. He went down every street of the town with a soldier beating the drum in front of him and stopped at every corner and cried it. *By order of His Excellency the governor. Let everyone go out to see Gloria Leal. Everyone, except those who are guarding houses. Anyone who does not go will pay a fine of eight reales.* And the governor sent to the friary to ask that the Father Guardian and his friars go too.

We'll go, said Fray Lucas.

Fray Gil had been lying on his habit for four days. He had not eaten. He had not spoken. The rice in the bowl on his shelf had rotted, and in the wet heat of that June a grey-green fur had grown up over the cloth that covered it. His brothers came to the door of the cell and said, *Fray Gil. The Father Guardian is going out to see Gloria Leal. Will you come?*

At her name he was on his feet. *I'll come,* he said.

He took the bowl down off the shelf and pulled off the cloth and threw the rice out the window to the hens, and went to the cistern and scrubbed the bowl with sand until it was clean, and put it in his sack, and went out to the gate with the others.

V. The Crier

The cleared ground · the fourth day

THE WHOLE TOWN WAS THERE. THE FRIARS STOOD TOGETHER on one side of the bier, Fray Lucas at their head. On the other side stood everybody else, each in their place, the way they stood at processions. The officers of the garrison and their wives in front, and the merchants, and Maestro Pedro with his hat in his hands. The soldiers. The women of the confraternities in their black. The free Black militiamen and their families. People from the Christian Indian towns outside the lines, who had come down because the drum said everyone. Juana, who had combed her mistress's hair every morning for eleven years. At the back, standing a little apart where the road went down to the harbor, a few English sailors who did not know what was happening and had come to see.

Nobody went closer than ten paces. Many of them held cloths to their faces, and some of them held oranges cut in half.

Fray Lucas looked a long time at the bier. Then he turned to the governor's adjutant.

Who is this woman?

The adjutant thought he had misheard. *Father, it's Gloria Leal. The surgeon's sister.*

This is Gloria?

Yes, Father.

Then let her be sold, said Fray Lucas. *Have your crier cry it the way he cries the goods of dead men in the plaza. Whoever will give an onza of gold for her, let him take her.*

The adjutant looked at Domingo de la Cruz, and Domingo looked at the adjutant, and then Domingo stepped up beside the bier with the drum behind him and lifted his head and cried it, in the voice everybody knew. *An onza of gold! Who gives an onza of gold for Gloria Leal?*

Nobody said anything. Nobody so much as cleared his throat.

They won't take her, Father, said the adjutant.

Then bring the price down.

Eight pieces of eight! cried Domingo. *Who gives eight pieces of eight for Gloria Leal?* Nobody. *Four! Two! One piece of eight!* The drum beat after each one. The buzzards on the palisade lifted at the sound and came down again. *Four reales! Two reales! One real for Gloria Leal!* Nobody. *Half a real! A copper! Who gives one copper for her?* Nobody moved. Some of the English sailors were laughing, uneasily, the way men laugh in church. A child began to cry and was hushed.

For nothing! cried Domingo. *Take her for nothing! Whoever wants her, take her away for nothing!*

Nobody said anything.

Maestro Pedro had not moved through any of it. He stood in the front with the officers, his hat in his hands, looking at the ground between his boots. He had held his sister's wrist while she died and combed her hair for the bier, and he did not look at the bier now, and he did not look away from it either. Once, when Domingo cried *one real,* his lips moved, and the officer beside him said afterward that he had been saying the price along with the crier, under his breath, the way a man counts.

Father, said the adjutant, *nobody will take her. Not even as a gift.*

Fray Lucas turned to his friars.

Look, he said. *That is what a woman is worth to the multitude. In this town an English captain paid an onza of gold for one night of her, and told it all the way to Charles Town, and the officers of the garrison paid what they had, and you have all heard what Fray Bernardo says at table. Three months ago half the*

men here would have sold their boots for her. Now nobody will carry her away for nothing. That beauty is gone where beauty goes. Look at this body. Look at it, brothers. Don't look away.

Domingo de la Cruz stood beside the bier with his hands at his sides. He had cried prices for thirty years, and he had never once in all that time been unable to sell a thing. He did not know what to do. He turned to the Father Guardian and asked him, quite simply, the way he would have asked the governor, *Father, what shall I cry now?*

Fray Lucas told him. Domingo lifted his head and cried it out over the cleared ground, in the same voice he had used for the prices, to the friars and the officers and the soldiers' wives and the Indian families and the English sailors at the back, and the buzzards rose all together off the palisade and went up into the white sky.

> *The voice of one, saying: Cry. And I said: What shall I cry? All flesh is grass, and all the glory thereof as the flower of the field.*
>
> *— Isaias 40:6*

Fray Gil was standing at the end of the line of friars, with his clean bowl in his sack. He had been looking at the thing on the bier since he came through the gate. He went on looking. The people near him said afterward that he did not weep and did not pray out loud and did not fall down. He only stood there with his hands open at his sides while the fever went out of him, the way the color goes out of a coal, and then he put his hands in his sleeves like any friar at any burial and bowed his head. Many others on that ground saw something that morning that they did not forget, and some of them changed their lives over it, and the town talked about it for years. But Fray Lucas, walking back through the gate, put his hand on the young man's shoulder and left it there, and did not say anything.

VI. Coquina

The friary · that summer

They buried her that evening in the grave she had paid for, before the altar of Our Lady in the friars' church, with the shutters open and the doors open and a great deal of incense. Juana walked behind the coffin. So did Doña Inés Salgado, in black, and Maestro Pedro, and Domingo de la Cruz, and all eight of the friars who had eaten at her table, and some of the wives who had crossed the street. Fray Lucas said the Mass himself. When it was over he stood at the edge of the open grave with the holy water and said one thing more over it, quietly, the way he said everything, so that the people near him had to lean in.

> *Favour is deceitful, and beauty is vain: the woman that feareth the Lord, she shall be praised.*
>
> *— Proverbs 31:30*

Then they closed the grave and laid the flagstone over it.

• • •

Fray Gil did not go back up the coast that summer. He asked to stay and work on the new friary, and Fray Lucas let him. Every morning before light he went across the bay in the boat to the King's Quarry on Anastasia Island with the masons and the hired men, and cut coquina out of the pit, and loaded it, and rowed it back.

Coquina is soft when it first comes out of the ground, so soft it can be cut with an axe, and it is no good for building until it has lain out in the sun and the rain for a year or more and hardened. So the stone Fray Gil cut that summer was not the stone he laid. He stacked his blocks to dry at the edge of the quarry, and in the afternoons he carried other blocks, cut before he ever came to Florida, up from the boats to the masons. If you look at coquina closely it is not one thing. It is shells. It is thousands upon thousands of little shells, the small bright clams that live in the wash of the surf along that whole coast, pink and white and yellow and

violet, every one of which was once alive and once beautiful, broken and packed together and pressed down under the sea until they were stone.

At noon the masons sat in the shade of the half-built walls and ate, and Fray Gil sat with them with his bowl on his knees and ate whatever was in it, corn or fish or nothing, and when he had finished he washed the bowl and set it upside down on a block of coquina to dry in the sun. Then he went back to work, and lifted the next stone onto the last one, with its thousands of shells in it, and the mason set it level, and Fray Gil went down to the boat for another.

Background

The verse

> *Look at this dressed-up lump, covered with wounds, joined together, sickly, full of many thoughts, which has no strength, no hold!*
>
> Dhammapada 147, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Sirimā is a celebrated courtesan of Rājagaha and the sister of the physician Jīvaka. After wronging the devout laywoman Uttarā, she comes to ask her pardon while the Buddha is eating at Uttarā's house, hears him teach that anger is overcome by kindness and evil by good, and becomes a disciple. From then on she feeds eight monks every day, lavishly. One monk praises her food and her beauty so warmly that another monk falls in love with her without ever having seen her, and contrives to be among the eight the next morning. She is ill that day and is carried out trembling to greet the monks; he goes home unable to eat, and she dies that evening. The Buddha asks King Bimbisāra not to burn her body but to leave it under guard in the charnel ground. On the fourth day, with the body swollen and crawling with maggots, the king has a drum beaten through the city and fines anyone who stays away, and at the Buddha's word offers her body for a thousand coins, then less and less, down to an eighth of a coin, then for nothing, and nobody will take her. The Buddha speaks the verse on the body, and the lovesick monk reaches the first stage of awakening. Read the full commentary story.

St. Augustine, Spanish Florida

San Agustín, 1736

In the first half of the eighteenth century, St. Augustine was a poor garrison town that could barely feed itself. The royal subsidy from Mexico, the situado, came irregularly and sometimes not for years. Carolina forces had burned the town in 1702, sparing only the Castillo de San Marcos, and English and Creek raids destroyed most of the interior Franciscan missions; their surviving Christian Native families resettled in small towns close to the city. Trade with the English was illegal but went on openly, and according to the Florida Museum one observer in 1736 counted six English merchant ships in the harbor at once.

The Franciscans' friary at the south end of town, burned in 1702, began to be rebuilt in stone in 1735; the building survives as the St. Francis Barracks. Its stone, like the Castillo's, was coquina, a rock made of shell fragments, quarried on Anastasia Island across the bay. Coquina is soft when first cut and has to dry for a year or more before it can bear weight. The town's northern edge was the Cubo Line, an earthwork of earth and palm logs with a palisade and a moat, running from the Castillo to the San Sebastián River.

After the story of Sirimā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 147). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

II.3

The Hem

Because man shall go into the house of his eternity, and the mourners shall go round about in the street.
— Ecclesiastes 12:5

Así lo oí contar, in Agaña.

I. The Rounds

Agaña, on Guam · the hungry year, 1706

Nobody in Agaña knew how old she was. She had been an old woman already when the padres came, and that was thirty-eight years ago. The padres had baptized her Isabel, but most people called her the one from lågu, because she had come down from the islands to the north, from the north and from the sea side of everything, when the soldiers brought the last of her people to Guam in the boats that were not burned. She was the last one left of all those boats. Her husband was dead, and her sons, and her sons' sons, in the fighting and the sicknesses and the crossing. She lived with a widow from Pago in a house of wood and thatch below the church, and every morning, while it was still cool, she went on her rounds.

She went to the houses where somebody was sick or somebody had died. There was always one. In the year of the spotted sickness there had been so many that she went to eleven houses in a morning, and in this year, the hungry year, they were dying again, slower, of the hunger and the sickness that comes after the hunger. She went in and knelt on the mat by whoever was lying there and led the prayers the padres had taught, the Our Father and the Hail Mary and the long ones for the dead, in a high hard voice that went up through the thatch. The household

answered her. When she was young she had wailed over the dead in the old way, the way the women did it then, and some of the old people said that the new prayers in her mouth sounded like the old wailing and that was why she was asked for. She did not say whether they did.

Afterward the household gave her what it had. A little cake of fadang, washed many days in the stream until the poison was out of it. A handful of rice in a leaf. A piece of breadfruit. In the hungry year it was very little, and sometimes it was nothing, and then they apologized and she touched their faces and went on to the next house. What she was given she carried home in a little basket of coconut leaf, plaited tight, that she had made herself, and in the evening she and the widow from Pago ate it.

She walked slowly. She wore the long skirt that the padres had urged on all the women when they came, the cloth that came on the ship from Manila, and she had never in thirty-eight years got used to the weight of it around her legs. She had got smaller, too, the way the very old get smaller, so that the skirt she had worn for twenty years now dragged in the dust behind her heels. The widow from Pago kept saying she would cut it. She had not cut it.

II. The Boy

The plaza wall · the last days of May

On the way home on the first day she met a boy from the colegio.

The colegio stood beside the church on the plaza, and the boys of Agaña went there from the time they were small to learn their letters and the doctrine and to sing in the church. This one was perhaps eleven. He had the high voice that the padres put at the front of the singing, and he was so thin that his shoulders stood up under his shirt like the frame of a roof. He was sitting on the plaza wall in the shade with his knees drawn up, waiting for something or for nothing.

She stopped in front of him and held out the basket.

May I give you this?

He looked at it, and at her. Then he said yes, and took it with both hands, the way the padres had taught the boys to take a thing that is given, and opened it. There was a cake of fadang in it and a little rice. He ate all of it there on the wall, slowly, while she stood and watched him, and then he handed her back the basket. She went home with it empty.

The second day she met him in the same place, on the wall in the same shade, and asked him the same thing, and he said yes. The third day it was the same. On each of the three days she gave him all she had been given, and on each of the three evenings she told the widow from Pago that she had eaten at the houses, which was not true, and lay down in the dark with the hunger moving in her like a small animal looking for a way out.

III. The Procession

The plaza · Corpus Christi, June 3

The fourth day was the great feast, and all of Agaña was in the plaza.

They had built altars at the corners under arches of palm, and the soldiers of the garrison stood in two lines in their coats with their muskets. The bells began before the sun was over the hill. The procession came out of the church with the padres under a canopy and the Host in its gold sun, and the boys of the colegio walked ahead of it in rows, two by two, singing the doctrine, and the men with the trumpets and the shawms came behind. At each altar the whole crowd went down on its knees in the dust while a song was sung, and then got up again and moved on, and the soldiers fired a volley into the air that made the children shriek and the dogs run under the houses. Every Chamorro left on the island who could walk to Agaña seemed to be there, all of them in their Manila cloth, pressed together along the edges of the plaza in the heat.

She had not gone on her rounds that morning, because of the feast. She stood near the colegio wall with the widow from Pago and watched the boys come by. She saw her boy among them, in the front row, with his

mouth open in the high part of the song. She was light in the head. The bright plaza moved a little, the way the sea moves under a canoe.

Walking at the side of the boys, keeping them in their rows, was the maestro.

He was a Chamorro of Agaña, a man of perhaps fifty, and he had been one of the first boys of the colegio himself, in the year it was built, when the walls were thatch and the padres who taught him were the ones who were later killed. He had learned the letters and the doctrine and the padres' tongue, and when he was grown they had made him the teacher of the doctrine to the children, and he had done it ever since. He taught in the plaza in the mornings, sitting on a stone. He said very little. When the children did not know their answers he waited until they did. People who had a quarrel brought it to him, and he listened to the whole of it and said one thing, and the quarrel was usually over. He was the only one in Agaña, it was said, whom the padres asked for his opinion and the old people asked for theirs.

He came along the edge of the crowd beside the boys, and the crowd made room for him, and when he came to where she stood, the old woman stepped back to let him pass. She stepped back onto the hem of her skirt. Her heel came down on the cloth, and the cloth held, and she went over backward into the dust under the colegio wall, all at once, like a bundle set down.

The singing went on. The canopy went on. The maestro stopped.

He left the boys and came and knelt in the dust beside her, and put his hand under her head. The widow from Pago was kneeling on her other side. People were turning to look. The old woman lay with her eyes open, looking up at him, and felt how light she was, and how far away her feet were at the end of her, tangled in the cloth.

Grandmother, said the maestro. *You have not eaten.*

She did not say anything.

Three days you gave it to the boy. He did not ask how she knew he knew. *This body is worn out, grandmother. It has carried you a long way, from lågu and all the way here. It is worn out, and soon it will come apart.*

He said it plainly, the way he told a child the answer to a question in the doctrine, and then, kneeling there, he said to her the words of the Preacher that the padres had taught him long ago and that he had put into their own language for the old people, so that they could hear it. She had heard it before. She had heard it at the houses of the dead.

> *Remember thy Creator in the days of thy youth, before the time of affliction come, and the years draw nigh of which thou shalt say: They please me not:*
>
> *Before the sun, and the light, and the moon, and the stars be darkened, and the clouds return after the rain:*
>
> *When the keepers of the house shall tremble, and the strong men shall stagger, and the grinders shall be idle in a small number, and they that look through the holes shall be darkened:*
>
> *And they shall shut the doors in the street, when the grinder's voice shall be low, and they shall rise up at the voice of the bird, and all the daughters of music shall grow deaf.*
>
> *And they shall fear high things, and they shall be afraid in the way, the almond tree shall flourish, the locust shall be made fat, and the caper tree shall be destroyed: because man shall go into the house of his eternity, and the mourners shall go round about in the street.*
>
> *Before the silver cord be broken, and the golden fillet shrink back, and the pitcher be crushed at the fountain, and the wheel be broken upon the cistern,*
>
> *And the dust return into its earth, from whence it was, and the spirit return to God, who gave it.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 12:1–7*

The mourners shall go round about in the street. She had gone round about in the street every morning for thirty-eight years. She had knelt by perhaps a thousand bodies, more, and touched them, and prayed them out of the world in the high voice, and walked home with what their people gave her. She had never once, in all of it, thought that the body on

the mat was the same kind of thing as the body she knelt in. She thought it now, lying in the dust of the plaza with the shawms going by. The keepers of the house trembling. The grinders few. The hem gone long because the one inside it had grown short. It was not a thing that was going to happen to her. It was a thing that was happening, that had always been happening, to the whole of her, the way the stream works the poison out of the fadang a day at a time.

She began to laugh. It was a small sound, and the widow from Pago thought she was weeping, and then saw that she was not.

The people standing nearest had heard all of it. A woman from Agat who had buried four children in the spotted sickness knelt down in the dust beside the widow. An old man went down on his knees too, and then a soldier's wife, and for a little while there was a ring of them there under the colegio wall, kneeling around the old woman while the procession went on to the next altar without them and the volley went off and the dogs ran. Some of them said afterward that they had understood something there that they had not understood at any of the altars. They did not say what. The maestro stayed until she could sit up. Then he went back to his boys.

IV. The Leaf

The house below the church · that evening

At dusk the boy from the colegio came to the door of the house below the church. He had a cake of fadang in his hands, wrapped in a leaf, from the padres' kitchen.

He held it out to her.

May I give you this?

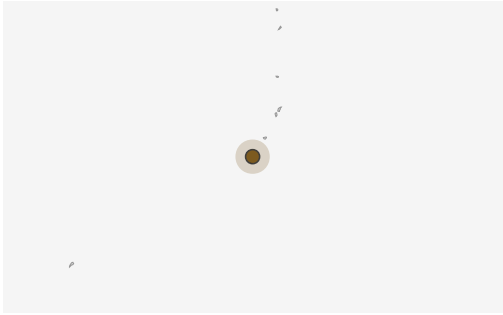
She said yes. She sat on the step and ate all of it, slowly, while he stood and watched, and when it was gone she smoothed the leaf flat on her knee and handed it back to him, and he went up the hill to the colegio in the last light, folding it smaller and smaller as he walked.

Background

The verse

> *This body is wasted, full of sickness, and frail; this heap of corruption breaks to pieces, life indeed ends in death.*
>
> Dhammapada 148, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the nun Uttarī is a hundred and twenty years old and still goes on her alms round every day. One day, coming back with food in her bowl, she meets a monk in the street, asks whether she may give it to him, and gives him all of it. She does the same on the second day and the third, and has none left for herself. On the fourth day she meets the Buddha in a crowded place, steps back to make way, treads on the hem of her robe and falls. He tells her that her body is worn out with age and will soon break up, and speaks the verse. At the end of it she enters the stream, and many others who hear it are helped. Read the full commentary story.



Hagåtña (Agaña), Guam

Guam, 1706

The Jesuit mission of Diego Luis de San Vitores reached Guam in 1668, and the Spanish–Chamorro Wars that followed lasted almost thirty years. War, the destruction of the canoes, forced removals from the northern islands and repeated epidemics (among them smallpox in 1699 or 1700) brought the Chamorro people near to vanishing; deaths from hunger are recorded in 1706, and a Spanish census of 1710 counted about 3,500 Chamorros alive. The survivors were gathered into six church-centered villages, Agaña (Hågatña) chief among them (Guampedia). Women who had worn little before the mission began to cover themselves at the missionaries' urging. On Guam, *lågu* means north, and in its older sense, toward the sea. Flour from the seeds of the native cycad, *fadang*, was a traditional food on the island until the 1960s.

San Vitores founded the Colegio de San Juan de Letrán in Agaña in 1669 for Chamorro boys, who learned their letters and the doctrine there; mission reports describe the children singing the doctrine in procession, and the Corpus Christi feast of 1677 with altars, songs at each station, dances and militia volleys. The *techa*, the lay prayer leader, most often an elderly woman, who leads the rosaries and novenas for the dead in a high, steady chant, is thought to date from at least the Spanish period; her chanting has been compared to the mourning of the dead at ancient Chamorro funerals. The old woman, the boy and the maestro are invented.

After the story of the elder nun Uttarī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 148). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

11.4

The Night Board

So Jonah was exceeding glad of the gourd.
— Jonah 4:6

Slik har jeg hørt det, above Hegge's Drug in Sundal.

I. The Board

Sundal, Sheridan County, Montana · 1950

The telephone exchange was two rooms over Hegge's Drug, up a stair so steep the lineman said it was built for goats. The front room held the board. It was oak, older than most of the town, with a hundred and twenty jacks in brass rows and a little lamp over each one, and the cords came up out of the shelf on lead weights and went back down when you let them go. The back room held a cot, a hot plate, a coffee pot and a window that looked north across the flats toward Canada, nineteen miles off, where there was nothing to see but more of the same.

Thea Solum worked the board from seven at night until seven in the morning, six nights a week, and had since the fall of 1929. Her husband had gone through the ice on Medicine Lake the winter before, after a coyote, and the company needed a night girl, and she was forty-three. She was sixty-four now. The town still called her the night girl.

She knew who was sick before the doctor did. When the lamp came up for the Fjeld place at two in the morning, she knew it was the baby with the croup again, and had the doctor's line ringing before Mrs. Fjeld finished saying his name. She knew when the cows were calving and when a man had come home drunk and when a woman was calling her sister in Williston because she could not stand it one more night. She knew all of

it and never repeated a word. People said that if you told her your sins she would only say, *Number, please.*

Sundays she taught the young people's class at the Full Gospel Tabernacle, which met in the old Danish hall on the Antelope road. She had taught most of the young men in the county to sit still for an hour, which was more than their fathers had managed. Five of them had stayed in her class past high school and past the war: Orrin Bakke, Leland Fjeld, Duane Sorby and the two Moen brothers, Gilbert and Vern. They farmed with their fathers, wheat and flax, and they were all between twenty and twenty-five, and none of them was married.

In the summer of 1949 word came down from Saskatchewan about the revival at North Battleford: that the rain had fallen at the Sharon school, that young people there had fasted forty days, that the gifts were being given now by the laying on of hands. Men drove up from all over the plains to see it. The Assemblies of God put out a resolution against it that fall, and the Tabernacle in Sundal split over the resolution the way churches split, at a potluck, over the coffee.

The five went north in the summer of 1950. They came back in August with their faces scrubbed and light, and said that hands had been laid on them, and that a prophet had told each of them in turn that he was called to be one of the overcomers. The sons of God were going to be made manifest before the end. Some of the men up north were teaching that the overcomers would not see death.

Before they went, Thea had given each of them the same verse on a three-by-five card in her square hand. She told them to pray it every day and not to skip it because they liked another one better.

> *Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts: And see if there be any wicked way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting.*
>
> *— Psalm 139:23–24*

They carried the cards to Saskatchewan and back.

II. The Wagon

The Big Muddy breaks · September and October 1950

After harvest they went into the breaks south of the Big Muddy, where Gilbert's uncle kept a sheep wagon on a bench above the creek, and they fasted there twenty-one days. They took water and nothing else. They read aloud by a coal-oil lantern, Romans eight mostly, over and over. *For the earnest expectation of the creature waiteth for the manifestation of the sons of God.*

The first week was hunger and quarreling, and Duane walked out twice and came back. The second week was cold, with frost on the wagon sheet in the morning and the sheep dog sleeping across the door to keep them in. In the third week something gave way.

It came to each of them a little differently and they told it to each other in the dark. Leland said it was like the wagon had been lifted off the ground and set down somewhere quieter. Vern said his body had gone, he could not feel the bunk under him, only a light that came up from inside and stayed. Orrin wept for two days without being sad. They stopped being hungry. They stopped being cold. They stopped, they all agreed, wanting anything at all. Not food, not land, not girls, not the new Ford tractor in the window at Plentywood. The flesh had died in them, they said. They had come through.

On the twenty-second day they walked out of the breaks to the road and Gilbert's father picked them up in the grain truck and did not say a word the whole way, because he had never seen faces like that on anybody and did not like it.

They decided to tell Thea first. It was right to. She had given them the cards.

III. The Stair

Sundal · the first week of November 1950

They went up Main Street a little after nine, in a dry snow that blew across the street without settling, and stood at the foot of

THE EXCHANGE STAIR. OLD ELMER HAALAND WAS SITTING AT the bottom of it in his sheepskin, where he sat most nights with a thermos, because he was the town's night marshal and there was nothing in Sundal to marshal. He ran messages up the stair for her when the board was too busy for her to leave it, which it never was.

Elmer went up. They could hear the cords drop on their weights and the little ring of the night bell, and her voice saying, *Number, please,* and then a long time nothing.

He came back down.

She says not to come up yet, he said. *She says first go sit with old Torger Lund. They've got him laid out in the front room at the farm and the boy's not in from Seattle till Thursday. She says go sit up with him and come back after.*

None of them asked why. Orrin said to the others in the truck, *She's got a reason.* She always had a reason. And they drove out to the Lund place, eleven miles west on the section line, in the snow.

IV. Two Houses

The Lund farm and the Haugen farm · November

TORGER LUND HAD DIED ON SATURDAY AT EIGHTY-ONE, IN HIS chair, and the undertaker from Plentywood had come out and done what he did, and then they had laid him on a board across two sawhorses in the cold front room, with the stove door shut and the storm windows on, to keep until his son came. It was Monday. The neighbors were taking the nights.

The five sat up with him on kitchen chairs. They sang a little, low, so as not to bother Mrs. Lund upstairs. The lamp was turned down. Torger's face had gone the color of a candle and fallen in around the teeth, and his hands on his chest were yellow at the nails. The room smelled of cold and of the undertaker's fluid, and under that of something else, faint and sweet, that the cold could not quite keep down. By the second hour Duane had gone out on the step twice for air.

But they were steady. They looked at the old man and felt nothing but a mild distaste, the way you feel about a dead calf in a slough, and they

were glad of the nothing. In the truck at dawn Leland said it for all of them. *You see? Not one thing in us that wants what that is. It's dead.* And they drove back to town light as boys, to tell her.

Elmer was at the foot of the stair again. He did not go up this time. He already had the message.

She says the Haugen girl. She says go on out there and sit up tonight.

They had not heard. Marit Haugen was nineteen. She had gone off the grade east of Antelope that afternoon in her father's Hudson, in the first real snow, on her way home from her job at the creamery, and the car had turned over once in the ditch and set itself back on its wheels, and she was dead when Elmer got there. Thea had put the call through to him herself, at a quarter past four.

They had known Marit all their lives. She had been in the young people's class at the Tabernacle until her people went back to the Lutherans, and every one of them had looked at her across the hall at one potluck or another. She had raised gourds for 4-H, the little striped ones and the white ones shaped like pears, and won with them at the fair in Plentywood, and every fall she set the white ones on the sills of the front room to dry.

They were on the sills that night. The undertaker had come and gone. Marit lay in the front room on the board her father had made from a door, under a quilt to her shoulders, in the blue dress she had worn to the fair. Her mother had washed her hair and combed it out across the pillow. There was no mark on her face. The cold of the room had not yet done anything to her. She looked as if she had come in from the snow and lain down.

They sat on the kitchen chairs and began to sing, low, and one by one they stopped singing.

Vern was the first to know. He was looking at her mouth. He had sat behind her in a Ford coupe once on the way to a box social, the summer he was sixteen, and had thought about her hair for a year. He thought about it now, with her mother in the kitchen and her father in the barn because he could not stand the house, and the thought did not stop where he told it to. It went on into the rest of her, under the quilt, as eas-

ily as it had ever gone anywhere. He sat with his hands on his knees in the presence of the dead and wanted her.

He did not look at the others, and they did not look at him. Every one of them, they admitted long afterward, believed he was the only one. Leland put his face in his hands. Gilbert went out on the step and stood in the snow without his coat until his brother came out and stood with him, and neither one said why.

At the Lund place it had been a dead old man and they had felt nothing, and they had called the nothing victory. It had only been distaste. Here was a dead girl as fresh as bread, and everything they had sworn was dead in them was sitting up on a kitchen chair in a farmhouse east of Antelope with its eyes open. It had never died. It had been asleep in the breaks, in the cold, with nothing to eat.

V. Three O'Clock

The Haugen farm · that night

THE CLOCK ON THE SHELF SAID THREE. MARIT'S MOTHER HAD gone up. The lamp was low and the stove had burned down and the five of them sat in a row along the wall where they could not see one another's faces.

Then they could see them. There was light in the room, not much, as much as comes off snow under a moon, though there was no moon that night. It came from the kitchen doorway. Thea Solum was standing there in her brown cardigan, with her reading glasses on the cord around her neck and her headset pushed down around her collar the way she wore it when she went for coffee, and the light was coming off her.

She did not come into the room. She looked at the girl on the door, and the white gourds on the sills, and the five of them along the wall.

Is this what you were coming up my stairs to tell me? she said. *You sit here with a board of bones like this, and you're glad?*

Nobody answered her. Then she said two verses, the way she had said them in class for fifteen years, plain, as if she were giving a number.

Son of man, can these bones live? And I answered, O Lord GOD, thou knowest.

— Ezekiel 37:3

Thou hast had pity on the gourd, for the which thou hast not laboured, neither madest it grow; which came up in a night, and perished in a night.

— Jonah 4:10

Then the doorway was dark, and the room was dark, and the stove ticked.

What happened to them in the next hour none of the five ever told well, though they were asked a good deal. Orrin said once that it was like the time the wagon was lifted, except that this time it was set down exactly where it had been, in the Haugens' front room, in the cold, with a dead girl on a door, and he was in it, and there was nothing wrong with any of it. They sat until the window went grey. Leland got up first and put coal in the stove, quietly, so as not to wake her mother. When Mrs. Haugen came down at six the five of them were sitting where she had left them, and she said afterward that she had never seen boys sit so still or look so ordinary.

VI. The Ticket

Sundal · the next morning

Elmer Haaland told it the rest of his life, in the drugstore and at the elevator, to anyone who would stand for it. He had sat at the foot of that stair from nine at night until seven in the morning, he said, with his thermos, the way he always did, and no one had come down it but him, and no one had gone up but him, and she had not left the board. He had heard her the whole night through the door. *Number, please.* And at five past three, he said, which was the exact time, she had put through the vet for the Sorby heifer that was calving backward, and at half past, a long-distance call to the hospital in Williston. It was on her tickets. Anybody could see the tickets. The company kept them in a drawer.

The five came up Main Street at a quarter to seven, as she was going off. Elmer stood aside. They went up the goat stair one at a time, which nobody but the lineman and the night girl ever did, and into the front room, and they knelt down on the oiled floor beside the board, all five, and put their foreheads on their hands, and stayed there.

The day girl came up behind them with her lunch pail and stopped in the door.

Get up, Thea said. *You'll scare Doris.*

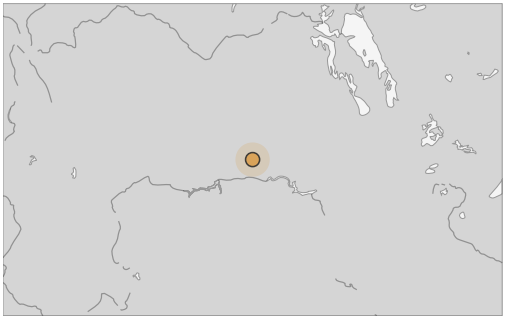
She took off her headset and hung it on its hook and plugged the day girl in, and put on her coat. On the shelf over the board, where she kept her coffee cup, there was a white gourd shaped like a pear, which Mrs. Haugen had brought in to her that morning on the milk truck because Marit had always meant her to have one, and it was not yet dry. When you shook it you could not hear the seeds. By spring you could, and she kept it there for years, until it went grey as a stone, and the night girls after her kept it, and nobody threw it out.

Background

The verse

> *Those white bones, like gourds thrown away in the autumn, what pleasure is there in looking at them?*
>
> Dhammapada 149, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Five hundred monks take a meditation subject from the Buddha into the forest, work hard, and reach deep absorption. Sure they are finished, they come back to report it. At the gate the Buddha sends word through Ānanda that they should first go to the charnel ground, and they go without asking why. Bodies a day or two dead disgust them, but the freshly dead stir their lust, and they see that their defilements are still in them. The Buddha, without leaving his chamber, sends a radiant image of himself to speak to them face to face: is it fitting, seeing such a heap of bones, to take delight? They reach awakening where they stand, and go to pay him homage. Read the full commentary story.



Sheridan County, Montana

Sheridan County, Montana, 1950

The Latter Rain revival began in February 1948 among students who had been fasting and praying at the Sharon Orphanage and Schools in North Battleford, Saskatchewan. Its first camp meeting that July drew thousands, and the movement spread fast through Pentecostal churches in Canada and the United States. Its leaders laid hands on believers with personal prophecy and taught that spiritual gifts could be passed on that way. Some taught that before the end a company of overcomers, the "manifest sons of God," would come into the full stature of Christ, and the boldest said they would step into immortality. The Assemblies of God's General Council condemned the "New Order of the Latter Rain" in 1949, and a good many congregations split over it.

Sheridan County lies in the far northeast corner of Montana against the Saskatchewan line, dry-land wheat country with Plentywood as its county seat and 6,674 people in 1950. Most of its farm families were Norwegian, Danish and German, and in the 1920s and 1930s it had been a center of radical farm organizing. Small towns on the plains still put calls through on manual switchboards, often in the operator's own rooms so someone could answer day and night, and customers knew their operator by name. The town of Sundal and everyone in the story are invented.

After the story of the many vain bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 149). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

11.5

Outward Adorning

> *Whose adorning let it not be that outward adorning of plaiting the hair, and of wearing of gold, or of putting on of apparel…*
> *— 1 Peter 3:3*

The way I heard it told, on Sycamore Fork.

I. Miss Guyandotte Valley

Logan County, West Virginia · 1998–2006

Crystal Hollins was the prettiest girl anybody in Logan County could remember, and in Logan County people remember. She was Miss Guyandotte Valley at eighteen, in a white gown her mother drove to Charleston to buy, and the picture of her in the sash with her hands folded and her hair down her back ran on the front of the Logan paper and stayed taped up in the window of the drive-in at Chapmanville until the sun bleached it blue. A man from a modeling agency in Columbus saw that picture and drove all the way down to give her his card, and she kept it in her wallet for nine years and never called him. Men who had known her since she was in diapers still turned around in the Walmart. Old women at the post office told her mother, *That girl could have been on television,* and her mother said, *Well, she could have.*

She was the baby of the family. Darrell was the oldest, fifteen years ahead of her, and Darrell had done what the Hollinses had always meant somebody to do. He had started with one dozer and a dump truck and a man who knew powder, and by 2002 Hollins Contracting had sixty men and a shop full of equipment and did the blasting and the hauling for the strip jobs from Blair to the Kentucky line. When a coal company wanted the top taken off a mountain, they called Darrell. People said he was the

king of Sycamore Fork. He had a house on the ridge with a three-car garage, and a son, Caleb, who was going to take it over.

In the spring of 2003 Darrell Hollins went to a revival at the little Holiness church at the mouth of Sycamore Fork because his wife asked him to, and went up to the altar on the second night, and did not come back down the same man. He sold the dozers and the drills and the trucks. He sold the house on the ridge. He paid off every man who worked for him with a year's wages and gave the rest away, so much of it and so fast that the bank in Logan sent a man out to the house to ask if he was all right. Then he moved into the parsonage behind the church, four rooms with a coal stove, and started to preach.

Inside of three years, people were driving from Mingo and Boone and Pike County, Kentucky, to hear him. They parked up and down the creek road on Sunday nights.

The rest of the Hollinses went after him one at a time. Caleb, at sixteen, was preaching beside him. Their mother, Wanda, who had worn slacks to the grocery store for forty years, let her hair grow and put on long skirts and joined the church at sixty-four. And Crystal's own husband, Travis Mullins, who had been on OxyContin since a piece of roof fell on him in the mine in 2001 and had sold her mother's wedding ring to get it, went down to Darrell's altar one night in 2005 and came up off the floor clean, and stayed clean, and took his guitar and went out on the road with Darrell to the revivals.

So by the summer of 2006 Crystal was the only one left. She had a tanning-and-nail salon in Logan called Crystal Clear, and a red Mustang, and a house on Sycamore Fork with nobody in it at night but her. She sat in the house and thought about it. Her brother had given up the strip jobs. His boy had given up the business. Her mother had given up her slacks. Her husband had given up everything there was to give up, and he was happy. Every one of them was over at that church.

Well, she said, to the kitchen. *Then I'm going too.*

It was not the Holy Ghost that took her there. She said so herself, years later. It was that she could not stand to be the only one on the outside of the window.

II. The Sisters

Sycamore Fork · 2006–2007

She sold the salon. She put her jeans and her shorts in a garbage bag and took them to the Goodwill in Logan, and bought long denim skirts and long-sleeved blouses. She washed off her makeup and did not put it back on. She stopped cutting her hair, which had never been cut much anyway, and learned from her mother how to twist it up and pin it, the way the Holiness women wear it, high on the back of the head. She took off her rings and the little gold cross she had worn since she was confirmed at the Methodist church in Chapmanville when she was twelve. The church called that outward holiness, and she kept every bit of it.

What she did not give up was the mirror. Every morning she stood in front of the bathroom glass on Sycamore Fork to pin up her hair, and every morning she looked a while longer than it took. Without the makeup her face was plainer, she could see that, and she could also see that it hardly mattered. Her skin was still what it was. Her eyes were still what they were. She would turn her head to one side and the other and think, with a little guilty pleasure she never told anybody about, that they could take away the lipstick and the gold and the jeans and the salon, and there was still this, and nobody could take this. Some mornings she caught herself smiling at it. Then she would pin the last pin and go to prayer meeting.

The sisters at church took her in like a lost calf. They called her Sister Crystal. They said, *Don't she look like an angel,* because even with her face scrubbed and her hair pinned up she did, and they could not help it any more than she could.

But she would not sit under Darrell's preaching.

She went on Wednesday nights when Caleb preached. She went to the sisters' prayer meetings in people's kitchens. She went on the Sundays Darrell was off holding revivals in Kentucky. When she heard his truck in the church lot she found something to do in the fellowship hall. Because she had heard what he preached. Everybody had. He had a sermon he was

known for, out of First Peter, the third chapter, on *outward adorning*, on the plaiting of the hair and the wearing of gold and the putting on of apparel, and how the flesh is grass and the body goes to the worms, and people said that when he preached it women went home and threw their curling irons in the creek. Crystal thought, *He'll find fault with me. If he gets a look at me up there, he'll find fault even with me.* So for a year her brother never once saw her face in his congregation.

After service on Sunday nights the sisters stood around in the gravel lot by their cars in the dark, under the one light on the pole, and talked about him. Crystal stood with them, because she had no way not to.

Sister Opal said she had never in her life seen a man's face shine like that when he was preaching. Like a light was on behind it.

Sister Rhonda said it was the voice. She said she would drive to Kentucky just to hear him read the begats.

Sister Faye said it was what he gave up. A man with sixty men under him and a three-car garage, and now he drives a 1991 Ford with no tailgate and owns one suit, and wears it to funerals and weddings and the pulpit both.

Old Sister Bernice, who was eighty-four and had been in the Holiness since 1939 and had heard every preacher in the coalfields, said it was none of that. She said it was that there was nothing crooked in him anywhere. She said, *I have looked for it,* and they laughed, and she did not.

Crystal listened to them and thought: they go on about him like he was Jesus. He's my brother. I know what he looks like with the flu. How much could he say about me in one night? And one night in July, in the lot, she heard herself say, *I believe I'll go to the revival.*

The sisters were so glad they hugged her. Sister Opal said she had prayed for it for a year. Sister Rhonda said, *Now he'll really preach.*

Crystal thought: I'll sit in the back behind the sisters. I'll see him and hear him, and he won't ever see me, and I'll leave before the altar call.

Darrell heard about it from his mother before the week was out. He sat at the kitchen table in the parsonage with his coffee and thought about his sister for a long time. He thought about the picture in the drive-in

window. He thought that you take out a splinter with a needle, and that some things you can only get out with the thing that put them in.

III. The Girl in Red

Little Sycamore Holiness Church · August 2007

THE MARQUEE SIGN OUT BY THE CREEK ROAD SAID REVIVAL AUG 12–19 BRO DARRELL HOLLINS ALL WELCOME, in red letters Caleb had put up on a stepladder. The rose of Sharon bushes along the church steps were in bloom, the pink kind with the red eye, where every flower opens in the morning and is shriveled on the ground by the next one. It was the third night of the revival and the church was full to the doors, with folding chairs down the aisle and men standing along the back wall with their hats in their hands. The windows were open and the box fans were going and it did not help. Every few minutes the windows shook in their frames, because the company that had bought Darrell's old contracts was still blasting on the strip job across the hollow, on what had been Cazy Mountain, and they blasted at four and again at seven.

Crystal came in late with the sisters and sat down in the next-to-last pew, right behind Sister Opal and Sister Rhonda, whose hair was pinned up so high that between the two of them she could hardly see the pulpit. That was why she had picked them.

Caleb led the singing. Travis played guitar. Then Darrell got up, and the church went quiet, and Crystal leaned a little to the side to look past Sister Rhonda's hair, and saw her brother for the first time in a year, standing behind the pulpit in his one suit with his Bible open, and his face did shine, she could not have said how. She thought: Opal's right. She thought: I'd forgotten.

Then she saw the girl.

She was standing just to the right of the pulpit, at the end of the altar rail, where nobody stands. She was about sixteen. She had on a long red gown that shimmered when she moved, with a rhinestone sash across it and a little rhinestone crown in her hair, and her hair was down, all the way down, dark and shining, past her waist. She was fanning herself with

one of the cardboard church fans from the pew racks, slowly, back and forth, and looking out at the congregation with a face like a full moon coming up over the ridge.

Nobody else saw her. Crystal knew that right away, the way you know things in dreams, from how nobody turned to look. Sister Opal did not see her. Sister Bernice, in the front row, did not see her. Only Crystal saw her. And Darrell, who never once looked at the girl, but stood beside her as if he knew exactly where she was.

Crystal could not stop looking. She looked at the girl's hair, and thought, oh, look at her hair. She looked at her forehead and her cheekbones and her bare arms and the way she held the fan, and the way the gown fell, and she thought of herself at that age in the white dress at the Guyandotte Valley pageant, which she had thought was the most beautiful she would ever be. And she understood that she had never been anything like this. Sitting there in her long skirt with her hair pinned up and no lipstick, she felt like a crow next to a swan. She wanted, more than she had wanted anything since she was a girl, to look like that.

IV. The Fan

The same night

Darrell began to preach. He did not preach out of First Peter. He did not preach about adorning at all. Crystal never could remember afterward what he preached about, because while he preached she was watching the girl, and the girl was changing.

It went slow at first. The girl was sixteen, and then she was twenty. That was all. But Crystal felt it go through her like cold water, and she thought, she's not the same. She's not as pretty as she was a minute ago.

Then the girl was holding a baby on her hip, and fanning the baby with the church fan, and her face had gone a little thick under the jaw and there were blue half-moons under her eyes. Then the baby was gone and she was forty, in a sweatshirt with a Dollar General name tag pinned to it, with a home permanent and reading glasses on a string around her neck, and she was rubbing the small of her back with one hand while she

fanned with the other. Crystal sat very still in the pew. She kept thinking, now that's gone. Now that's gone too.

Then the girl was old. Her hair was white and thin and her teeth were gone and her mouth had fallen in, and she was bent over nearly double, the way the old women on the creek get bent from a life of stooping, so bent she had to lean on a cane with both hands and could hardly lift her face to see the congregation. She trembled all over. The rhinestone crown hung crooked in what was left of her hair. She still had the fan, hooked over one finger.

Crystal looked at her and felt sick.

Then the sickness took the old woman. She dropped the cane and the fan both and cried out, and went down on the floor in front of the altar rail, and rolled back and forth on the carpet, and fouled herself, and lay in it. Up in the pulpit Darrell went on preaching. The box fans went on turning. Nobody in the church but Crystal saw any of it, and she sat with both hands over her mouth.

V. Bones

The same night

THEN THE OLD WOMAN ON THE FLOOR WAS DEAD.

Crystal watched it happen, and then watched what came after, all of it, in the time it takes to preach a sermon. The body swelled up in the red gown until the rhinestone sash cut into it. The face went dark. What was inside started coming out of every opening there is, and there were worms in it. And then the church was not a church any more but a bank by the side of the creek road, and the buzzards came down out of the sky in long circles and landed, and the crows came, and the dogs from the trailers came up out of the hollow and pulled at it, and pulled the red gown apart, and the bones came through.

Crystal looked at it, and something in her went down to the bottom and stopped.

She thought: that was her, and it happened right here. She got old right here, and got sick right here, and died right here. And it is coming

to me. It is coming to this body I am sitting in. It is not coming someday to somebody. It is coming to this.

Then she saw it was coming to everything. To the sisters in front of her, and their high pinned hair. To her mother. To Travis with his guitar. To every face in the church, and every face in the Walmart, and the picture in the drive-in window. It was like seeing every house on the creek on fire at once, in the night, and knowing there was not one of them you could go back into. She wanted out. Not out of the church. Out of all of it.

Up in the pulpit Darrell stopped preaching in the middle of a sentence.

He had seen, in her face, what she had seen. He had seen too that it had taken her down to the bottom and that she did not know how to stand up on it by herself. So he came out from behind the pulpit and down the two steps, and walked up the aisle between the folding chairs, past the sisters, all the way back to the next-to-last pew, and stood at the end of it. The whole church turned around in their seats to see who he was looking at. It was the first time in a year he had looked his sister in the face.

He did not say anything about her face. He opened his Bible to where his thumb already was and read it out to her, quietly, as if there were nobody else in the building.

> *As for man, his days are as grass: as a flower of the field, so he flourisheth. For the wind passeth over it, and it is gone; and the place thereof shall know it no more.*
>
> *— Psalm 103:15–16*

Crystal looked up at him. She had been crying and did not know it. She felt something under her feet that had not been there before, something like a floor.

Darrell saw that too. He sat down beside her on the end of the pew, an old man's way of sitting, with his hand on his knee, and said it plain, the way he would have said it to her at the supper table when she was ten.

Sissy, there's nothing in it. There's not a thing in it to hold onto. It's a frame of bones they've plastered over, and painted, and what's inside is getting old, and dying, and proud of itself, and putting on a face. That's all it is. That's all mine is too.

Then he turned a few pages and read the hardest thing in the Book, the thing the Lord said to the preachers of His own day, and Crystal heard that he was reading it to himself as much as to her.

> *Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye are like unto whited sepulchres, which indeed appear beautiful outward, but are within full of dead men's bones, and of all uncleanness.*
>
> *— Matthew 23:27*

The windows shook. It was seven o'clock, and across the hollow they were blasting on Cazy Mountain.

Crystal Hollins sat in the next-to-last pew with her brother beside her and her hands in her lap, and the last of it went out of her, all of it, the white dress and the sash and the picture in the window and the crow and the swan, like the dust going out of the air after the blast. The sisters said afterward that she never went to the altar that night. She did not need to. She got up off that pew already standing on the other side of something.

VI. The Strip Job

Sycamore Fork · afterward

Sister Opal said, on the way out to the cars, that she had never seen anything like it, and Sister Rhonda said she had told them, didn't she tell them, now he'd really preach. Sister Faye said that was the first time anybody ever saw Darrell Hollins walk out of his own pulpit in the middle of a sermon. Sister Bernice did not say anything. She took Crystal's face in both her old hands in the gravel lot, under the one light on the pole, and looked at it a long time, and let it go.

Crystal never told the sisters what she had seen by the altar rail. She told Darrell once, years later, sitting on his porch, and he nodded and said he knew, and they did not talk about it again.

She did not make much of herself after that, in the church or out of it. She worked at the clinic in Logan, at the front desk, and then in the back with the old people, washing them and turning them in their beds, which she was good at and did not mind. She was the one the nurses sent for when somebody was dying and the family could not stand to be in the room. Women in the church who were scared of getting old came to her, and she sat with them at their kitchen tables and did not tell them it would be all right. She told them what it was. They said afterward it was the strangest thing, how that helped.

Her hair went grey early, in her thirties, all at once, and she let it. Travis came home off the road for good the next year and they lived quiet on Sycamore Fork, and when he said one night across the supper table that she wasn't as pretty as she used to be, he said it wondering, the way you'd say the creek was down, and she laughed until she had to wipe her eyes, because it was true and because she did not mind.

That fall she drove her mother up the ridge road to the overlook on a Sunday afternoon, the one where you used to be able to see Cazy Mountain from the porch of Darrell's old house. The company had finished with the top of it. Where the trees had been there was a long flat bench of grey rock, terraced and raw, with the seams showing through like the bones of something, and below it the valley fill where the hollow used to be, and a water truck going back and forth on it laying the dust. Her mother said, *Lord, look what they did.*

Crystal looked. Then she said, *It was always under there, Mama,* and put the car in reverse, and drove her mother home down the creek road in the last of the light.

Background

The verse

> *After a stronghold has been made of the bones, it is covered with flesh and blood, and there dwell in it old age and death, pride and deceit.*
>
> Dhammapada 150, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Rūpanandā, "Joyous Form," the Buddha's own half-sister and the most beautiful woman in the land, becomes a nun because everyone she loves has already left home to follow her brother: his son, her betrothed husband, her mother. She does it for love of them, not out of faith, and because she has heard that the Buddha calls the body impermanent and unsatisfying, she keeps out of his sight, sure he will find fault with her beauty. When the nuns finally bring her to hear him, she hides among them. The Buddha conjures a girl of sixteen in crimson, more beautiful than Rūpanandā, fanning herself beside him. As Rūpanandā watches, the girl ages, bears a child, grows old and bent, falls sick, dies, and is torn apart by crows and dogs. Seeing that the same is coming to her own body, Rūpanandā is shaken loose; the Buddha steadies her with verses, then tells her the body is a city of bones, and she reaches awakening. Read the full commentary story, or about Sundarī Nandā, as she is also known.

Logan County, West Virginia

Logan County, 2007

Logan County sits in the southern West Virginia coalfields along the Guyandotte River; it saw the Battle of Blair Mountain in 1921 and the Buffalo Creek flood in 1972. By the 2000s much of the coal there came from mountaintop removal, in which explosives take off as much as 400 feet of a summit to reach the seams beneath and the leftover rock is pushed into the hollows below as "valley fills." The method supplied about 30 percent of West Virginia's coal in 2006 and needed far fewer workers than underground mining. The same years brought the prescription-painkiller epi-

demic to the region; in May 2007 Purdue Pharma pleaded guilty to misleading the public about the addiction risk of OxyContin and agreed to pay $600 million.

Holiness and Pentecostal churches have deep roots in the Appalachian coalfields. Many of the more conservative ones keep what they call outward holiness: women do not cut their hair, wear dresses or skirts rather than trousers, and give up jewelry and makeup, citing among other passages 1 Peter 3, the verses on "outward adorning" that Crystal feared her brother would preach at her.

After the story of the Elder Janapada Kaḷyāṇī Rūpanandā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 150). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

II.6

One Shot

> *Every work that is corruptible shall fail in the end: and the worker thereof shall go with it.*
> *— Ecclesiasticus 14:20*

Así me lo contaron, on Highland Avenue.

I. The Wash Bay

National City, California · May 2023

Rey Pacheco had the tire and alignment shop on Highland Avenue that his father had before him, two bays and a rack, with the house behind it up a flight of outside stairs and the long garage behind that. He was sixty-one and had been president of the Monarcas Car Club for nineteen years. People in National City called him el Rey, and his name was only part of the reason. When a kid from the club got married, the cars lined up at his curb. When somebody's mother died, the envelope went around at his shop.

That was the spring the city took the NO CRUISING signs down. They had been up since 1992. For thirty-one years a man could be written up for passing the same corner of Highland twice in an evening with his car sitting low, and now the council had voted, every one of them, and a city truck came with a ladder. Rey stood on the sidewalk with half the club and watched a man in a vest unbolt the sign in front of the shop. He asked if he could have it. The man said he couldn't do that, and then looked at the faces, and left it leaning against the pole when he drove off.

Behind the second bay there was a wash bay, a concrete room with a floor drain and a hose reel, where the club cars got rinsed before a show. Rey had put a camera up in the corner of it the winter before, after some-

body came over the fence and took four wire wheels off a customer's Regal. It was a forty-dollar camera. It sent its picture to a screen in the office upstairs and to his phone.

On a Thursday in May, a little after closing, he was upstairs doing the deposit. His wife was down in the wash bay. Her name was Jazmín and everybody called her Mina. She had been hosing out floor mats for the Saturday show and had soaked herself to the knee, and she had washed her face at the spigot and was bent over rinsing the grit off her legs. Rey looked up at the screen for no reason at all.

The kid they called Perro came into the picture. He was twenty-four, a detailer, good with a buffer, at the shop since Christmas. He came up behind her and put his hands on her. She did not straighten up and she did not turn around. That was the part Rey would see afterward with his eyes shut. She let him. The counter in the corner of the screen ran eleven seconds before she moved, and then Perro was out of the picture and she was coiling the hose.

Rey sat a while. Then he went down the outside stairs. She was coming across the lot, drying her hands on her shirt.

¿Qué hiciste? he said. *What did you do?*

What did I do?

In the wash bay. With Perro. Don't, Mina. I saw it.

You saw what?

I saw it on the camera. I'm not going to believe anything you say to me. I saw it with my own eyes.

She looked at him for a moment. Then she laughed, one short breath.

That camera, she said. *Rey. That camera puts two where there's one. Everybody who walks into that bay comes out double on it. Monday it sent me a picture that said Person Detected and it was the mop bucket. It showed me two of the cat. It's got the AI in it, it makes things up. I was in there by myself.*

Don't lie to me.

Then go stand in there. Go on. I'll go up and watch the screen, and afterward you tell me what you were doing.

He was a man who believed people. It had made him a good president and a poor businessman. He walked into the wash bay and stood on the

drain with his arms hanging, feeling like a fool, and looked up at the little black eye in the corner. Upstairs she stood in front of the screen. Then her voice came down through the office window, loud enough for the alley.

Reynaldo! Who is that? Who's that in there with you? I see la Chiva hanging on your neck!

La Chiva was Silvia Robles, a widow, who parked her taco truck at the cruise nights and had never in her life given anybody cause.

There's nobody! Mina, I'm standing here by myself!

I'm looking right at it. I see it with my own eyes. Don't tell me.

He came out into the lot and looked back at the empty room, and then up at the window.

Then it's true, he said. *About the camera.*

I told you.

He got the stepladder that same evening and took the camera off its bracket and dropped it in the scrap barrel. That night in bed he said he was sorry. She said it was nothing, go to sleep.

II. Mañana

Highland Avenue · that night, and the year after

Mina Pacheco did not sleep. She was fifty-eight and had been married to him since she was twenty, and she lay on her side of the bed and went over it.

He believed me because of the way he is, she thought. *I used that. I did a low thing in the wash bay and then a lower one on the stairs. And I put Silvia in it, who never did anything to me but save me a plate. The first one was eleven seconds and I hardly knew I was in it. The second one I thought up.*

Then she thought about la Maestra, and that was worse.

Consuelo Ybarra had a paint shop on Newton Avenue in Barrio Logan, in sight of the bridge. She had been striping cars for forty years. She laid her lines with a squirrel-hair brush no wider than a shoelace and a can of lettering enamel, freehand, and there was not a club from San Ysidro to Oceanside that did not have her hand on a trunk lid somewhere. She was

also one of the painters who went up on the lifts under the Coronado Bridge every few years to bring the murals on the pillars back, when the sun off the bay had taken them down to chalk. She did not talk much. People said she could look at a fender and tell you who had done the bodywork under the paint and what kind of a week he'd been having. People said other things. She painted the dead, a portrait on a hood, a name on a quarter panel with wings, and it was known that she would sometimes tell a family *not yet* and would not say why, and a month or a year later call them up and say, bring the car.

She will know, Mina thought. *She'll look at me once over those glasses and know both things.*

By the end of the week Mina had paid Perro two weeks and he had gone to a shop in El Cajon. Nobody at the shop asked.

It had been Mina, with Rey beside her, who did the thing the clubs still talked about. Two summers back, for la Maestra's forty years, she had run a show at Kimball Park out of a spiral notebook: eleven clubs, a hundred and forty cars, carne asada plates at twelve dollars. The money paid off the note on the building on Newton Avenue. Nothing like it had been done for anybody. And with what was left over Mina bought four things she had picked out herself. A white umbrella nine feet across on a rolling base, so that a hood could be striped outdoors without the sun cooking the enamel under the brush. A daybed for the back of the shop, because la Maestra's spine was going and she needed to lie flat between jobs. A steel stand that would hold a trunk lid at any angle. A low stool on casters for doing rocker panels.

After that Thursday she gave more. It was the only thing that quieted her. A box fan. Reading glasses in three strengths. A case of mineral spirits, tamales at Christmas, a new tarp for the lift. *Mañana le llevo esto a la Maestra,* she would say, with the thing already in her hands, tomorrow I'll take this to la Maestra, and the next day she would drive it down to Logan and leave it with the boy at the front counter. In all that year she did not once walk back to the booth where the woman could look at her.

III. The Corner of the Ceiling

National City · winter 2024

On the first of January cruising was legal again in every city in California. The Monarcas went up Highland that night forty cars long behind the old Impala, slow, with the hazards going, and Mina sat in the passenger seat and waved at the sidewalks like the queen of something.

On a Tuesday in February she put her hand to the side of her head in the kitchen and said *Rey,* and sat down on the floor.

She was two days in the hospital on Fourth Street and woke once. Rey was there. He told her everybody was asking. He told her la Maestra had sent a candle. Then, because he did not know what else a person says, he started at the beginning and told her the good she had done, the way you would read someone her own record. The bikes at Christmas, six hundred in one year. The envelopes. The quinceañera dresses. The show at Kimball Park, the building note, the white umbrella.

It is told that she heard none of it. Her eyes had gone past him to the corner of the room where the wall met the ceiling tiles. There was a small dark dome up there, a sensor of some kind, and her eyes stayed on it.

La cámara, she said.

What camera, mi vida? There's no camera.

She did not look away from it. She died that night with the wash bay in her mind and the stairs and Silvia's name in her own mouth, and none of the rest, not one bicycle, not the umbrella.

The people on Highland Avenue who tell this say that she went where a person goes who dies holding on to a lie, and that she was there seven days. They say it plainly. Seven days she was in the fire for it.

He buried her on a Saturday. Thirty-some cars took her to La Vista at ten miles an hour, which nobody could ticket now. That evening his sister-in-law set a bowl in front of him and he ate what was in it and could not have told you afterward what it was. He sat in the kitchen with the light off.

I'll go and ask la Maestra, he thought. *They say she knows where they are. I'll ask her where Mina is.*

IV. Seven Days

Newton Avenue, Barrio Logan

He drove down on the Sunday. She was in the booth laying out a roof for a pattern job, and before he had his mouth open she put a roll of eighth-inch tape in his hand.

Hold that end.

He held it. She walked the tape down the length of the roof and came back and gave him another. While she worked she talked, which she hardly ever did. She talked about his father, who had come to her teacher's shop in 1979 wanting scrollwork on the Impala and had argued for an hour about the color of the line. Rey had not known that. He laughed. He was back on Highland with tape gum on his fingers before he remembered what he had gone for.

Tomorrow, he said to the kitchen.

On Monday she was laying gold leaf on a dash, the thin kind that lifts if you breathe on it, and he stood a yard off and took small breaths for an hour and watched her press it down with a ball of cotton. On Tuesday she took him under the bridge and had him steady a bucket on the lift while she went over the blue in a pillar forty feet up. She told him the one she was touching had been repainted in 2012, over the paint of 1978, over bare state concrete. *Ten or twelve years, facing the water,* she said. *Then you come back up.* On Wednesday she put a sanding block in his hand. On Thursday she said nothing at all, and he sat down on the daybed Mina had bought and slept the afternoon through, the first real sleep since the kitchen floor. Friday there was a Riviera to mask. Saturday she showed him how she put her brushes away, each one drawn through oil and shaped to an edge with two fingers and laid flat in the box.

Every evening it came back to him at his own gate.

They say she did it on purpose. For those seven days Mina was where she was, and la Maestra knew it, and knew the man. She did not tell

people things that were not so. If he had got his question out on the Sunday he would have had his answer, and he would have stood in that booth and thought: *Mina? Who gave the way she gave? Then what is any of it for.* He would have closed his hand. There would have been no more pot of menudo on Sunday mornings for whoever walked up the alley, no more envelopes, no bikes. A man who shuts his hand out of bitterness has a road in front of him too, and she could see down it.

So there was tape, and leaf, and the bridge, and sleep.

V. The Garage

Highland Avenue · the eighth day

On the eighth day she came to him. She came alone and on foot, up from the trolley at Eighth Street, a little before noon, with her striping kit on a strap over her shoulder. Rey saw her from the bay. He wiped his hands and went out and took the box from her, as you would, and started for the outside stairs to bring her up to the house, where the good chairs were. She did not follow. She had stopped at the open door of the long garage.

Aquí está bien, she said.

So he unfolded a chair for her there among the cars, and brought down what there was in the house: a bowl of caldo, tortillas he heated himself, and two conchas from the panadería. She ate all of it without hurry. He stood until she set the bowl down. Then he turned a bucket over and sat in front of her.

Maestra. Every day I came to you I had one thing to ask, and every day I got home with it still in my pocket. I want to know where Mina is. They say you know. Tell me.

Con Dios, she said. *She is with God, Rey.*

He nodded hard, several times.

Where else. If she isn't, who is? There wasn't another one like her. Sitting down, standing up, in the car, in the middle of the night, it was the same thing out of her mouth. Tomorrow I'll take this to la Maestra, tomorrow I'll do that for la Maestra. I used to tell her, Mina, the woman has four fans. He rubbed

his face with both hands. *Since she went I'm not here. This* (he hit his chest with the flat of his hand) *is parked. There's nobody in it.*

Don't grieve like that. This is how it goes with everything that's alive. It's the one rule that doesn't skip anybody.

From the chair she could see across the lot into the wash bay, as far as the corner where a steel bracket stuck out of the block wall with two empty screw holes in it. Rey saw where she was looking.

She said something about a camera, at the end. I had one there. It was no good, it showed double. I threw it out.

La Maestra looked at the bracket for about as long as it takes to pull a line down the side of a car. She did not say anything about it. Then she lifted her chin toward the far end of the garage.

Whose car is that?

My grandfather's. Thirty-nine Chevy, the Master Deluxe. He bought it in forty-six with cannery money.

It sat on four flat tires. The lacquer had gone to chalk and checked all over like the floor of a dry lake, and the rust had come through the rockers from the inside.

And that one?

My father's. The sixty-four. He bought it new on the Mile of Cars.

It had been shot in candy brandywine by her own teacher. On the hood and the roof, where forty summers had got at it, the candy had gone the brown-pink of a healed burn, and the old man's stripes were ghosts you could find only with the light behind you. It still ran.

And this?

Mine. The seventy-six Caprice, teal over silver, three years old in the paint and deep enough to put your arm into.

Your father's has outlasted your grandfather's, la Maestra said, *and yours has outlasted your father's. Look at them in a row. I have been putting paint on cars for forty years and I can tell you what I know about paint. The candy goes first. The prettier it is, the quicker the sun takes it. Then the clear. Then the steel.* She held out her right hand, the brush hand, with its big knuckles. *Then this. This goes quicker than the cars do, Rey. A car you can leave in a garage.*

She said the next part in English, flat, the way the sisters at the school in Logan had read it out of the black Bible when she was nine years old.

> *All flesh shall fade as grass, and as the leaf that springeth out on a green tree. Some grow, and some fall off: so is the generation of flesh and blood, one cometh to an end, and another is born. Every work that is corruptible shall fail in the end: and the worker thereof shall go with it.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 14:18–20*

That's the cars, and it's you and me. There is one line the sisters kept next to it.

> *For justice is perpetual and immortal.*
>
> *— Wisdom 1:15*

That part doesn't check and it doesn't fade. What a good person did right, the rightness of it. You can't park that anywhere and you don't need to. All you can do with it is hand it to the next one.

> *And the things which thou hast heard of me by many witnesses, the same commend to faithful men who shall be fit to teach others also.*
>
> *— 2 Timothy 2:2*

She opened the box. The brushes lay in it in their oil, and beside them the small cans. Rey's granddaughter had been sitting on the stairs the whole time with her chin on her knees. She was eleven, and she was Jazmín too, and they called her Jazzy.

Ven, said la Maestra.

She tore a page out of a magazine for a palette and put a thumbnail of white on it, and worked the brush in it until it was loaded to the heel. Then she bent to the dead grey fender of the thirty-nine and pulled one line, a long slow S the length of her arm, without lifting, breathing out the whole way.

The man who showed me that was Tavo Ruelas. The one who showed him was a sign painter in Tijuana whose name I never got. You load it full. You look

at where you're going and never at the brush. You pull it once and you don't go back over it. One shot. It says so on the can.

She put the brush in the girl's hand and stood behind her and did not touch her arm. The girl's line started fat and went thin and wandered off la Maestra's by the width of a finger at the end. La Maestra did not fix it. She pressed the lid back on the can with her thumb.

Rey walked her to the gate. When he came back the two lines were drying side by side on the old Chevy. They were white, the white Mina had picked for the umbrella, and on that fender they would be gone in a few summers. He left the garage door up so the afternoon could get at them.

Background

The verse

> *The brilliant chariots of kings are destroyed, the body also approaches destruction, but the virtue of good people never approaches destruction,—thus do the good say to the good.*
>
> Dhammapada 151, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi looks down from an upper window and sees Queen Mallikā in the bath-house misbehaving with her pet dog. She tells him that the window shows everyone in the bath-house double, sends him in to prove it, and calls down that she sees him with a she-goat; he believes her. She is the greatest giver in the kingdom, the one who arranged the Gifts beyond Compare and gave the Buddha a white parasol, a couch, a stand and a footstool, but she dies remembering only the lie and is reborn in hell for seven days. Each of those days the grieving king goes to ask the Buddha where she has been reborn, and each day the Buddha makes him forget the question, so that he will not lose heart and stop giving. On the eighth day the Buddha comes alone to the palace, sits in the chariot hall, and tells him she is in the Tusita heaven. Then he asks whose the three chariots are, the grandfather's, the father's and the king's own, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about King Pasenadi. The retelling turns the dog and the she-goat into two people with those nicknames and the window into a cheap camera; the king, as in the original, never learns the truth.

National City, California

National City and Barrio Logan, 2023–2024

Lowriding grew up among Mexican Americans in the Southwest after the Second World War: cars lowered, repainted in deep translucent "candy" colors over metallic bases, striped by hand, and driven slowly. Cars from before the fifties are called bombs. Pinstripers pull their lines freehand with a long-haired "sword" brush and lettering enamel, and the craft passes from one hand to the next. Cities answered the cruising scene with bans. National City, just south of San Diego, passed its ordinance in 1992, and its Highland Avenue was posted with No Cruising signs for three decades. After a campaign by the United Lowrider Coalition the city council voted unanimously to repeal the ban in April 2023. That October the governor signed Assembly Bill 436, which ended local cruising bans across California and the state rule against lowered cars, from January 1, 2024.

Chicano Park lies under the approach ramps of the San Diego–Coronado Bridge in Barrio Logan, a neighborhood cut in two by Interstate 5 in 1963 and by the bridge in 1969. Residents occupied the ground on April 22, 1970, to stop a Highway Patrol station from being built there. Painting of the bridge pillars began in 1973; some ten thousand square feet went up in a "mural marathon" in April 1978; and twenty-three murals were restored in a project that started in 2012. The park became a National Historic Landmark in 2016, and lowrider clubs show their cars there every Chicano Park Day. The Monarcas, the shops, and everyone in this story are invented.

After the story of Queen Mallikā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 151). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

II.7

Sixteen Oxen

For, lo, the winter is past; The rain is over and gone;
— Song of Solomon 2:11

Way I heard it, up on Clay Hill.

I. The Golden Wedding

Clay Hill, Merrimack County, New Hampshire · June 2022

Lyle Corliss had been chaplain of Clay Hill Grange No. 113 since the year Nixon resigned, and nobody had ever run against him. He was eighty-four. He was still the biggest man in any room he went into, with a neck like a fencepost and hands that had been broken by oxen more times than he could tell you, though he would try. He knew the opening prayer and the closing prayer by heart, and the grace, and the long part he said when the charter was draped for a member who had died. He had been saying all of them for forty-eight years.

The hall was white clapboard, built in 1896, two stories, with the suppers downstairs and the meetings upstairs. Upstairs there was an altar in the middle of the floor, and on it a big American Standard Bible that a summer family had given the Grange in 1904, its corners gone soft as felt. The Assistant Stewards opened it at the start of every meeting and closed it at the end. In the corners stood the stations of Ceres, Pomona and Flora, with a sheaf of wheat, a basket of wax apples and a jar of paper roses that had been there so long they had faded to the color of skin.

Bud and Arlene Fisk had been married in that hall in 1972, under a bell made of crepe paper, and in June of 2022 they came back for their fiftieth. There were sixty people, which was more than Clay Hill Grange had seen in one place since before the pandemic. There was punch, and a

sheet cake from the Market Basket in Concord with a gold 50 on it, and the Fisks' granddaughter had hung Christmas lights along the stage. After the cake the Master asked the chaplain to say a few words from Scripture over the couple.

Lyle stood up, which took a while. He had marked his place with an Agway receipt. He put on his glasses and read in the voice he used to read everything, the one he used to call a yoke of steers across a forty-acre field.

> *Man, that is born of a woman, Is of few days, and full of trouble. He cometh forth like a flower, and is cut down: He fleeth also as a shadow, and continueth not.*
>
> *— Job 14:1–2*

He closed the Bible and sat down. The Christmas lights blinked along the stage. Arlene Fisk went on smiling, because she had been smiling for an hour and her face did not know how to stop. Bud looked at his hands.

Well, Bud said finally, to the room. *That's so.*

Somebody laughed, and then everybody did, and the granddaughter put on a record.

II. The Charter

November 2022

Vernon Hatch died in the first week of November at ninety-three. He had joined Clay Hill Grange in 1952, and he had been Overseer, Master, Steward and Gatekeeper, and for one year, by a mistake in the balloting nobody ever cleared up, Flora. On the Tuesday after the funeral the Grange draped the charter for him.

The charter hung in a black frame on the wall behind the Master's station. For thirty days after a member died it wore a drape of black crepe, and the putting on of the drape was the chaplain's work, with Ceres and the two Assistant Stewards. Ceres was a girl of nineteen from the 4-H dairy club. The Assistant Stewards were the Fisks. Lyle walked to the al-

tar with the folded crepe over his arm and opened the Bible to the place he had marked with the receipt, and read.

> *For, lo, the winter is past; The rain is over and gone; The flowers appear on the earth; The time of the singing of birds is come, And the voice of the turtle-dove is heard in our land;*
>
> *— Song of Solomon 2:11–12*

Outside the windows it was sleeting sideways across the parking lot.

Dot Hatch was in the front row in her good coat. She put her face in her hands, and the people behind her thought she was crying, and she was, but when she took her hands away she was laughing too, and could not stop for a while, and Ceres had to bring her a glass of water.

Lyle hung the crepe on the charter as straight as a plumb line, because he had done it a hundred times. Afterward, downstairs over coffee, he said to Bud Fisk that he thought it had gone off all right.

That was the thing about Lyle. He never knew. He set out from his own kitchen with the right words in his mind, the way you set out with the right tool in your truck, and somewhere between his kitchen and the altar the words changed places, and he did not feel them change. At the 4-H show in August he had blessed the steers with a prayer for the sick. At the Christmas supper the year before he had read the passage about the rich man who pulled down his barns to build bigger and died that night, and the Grange had just finished paying for a new roof on its own barn out back. He gave the wedding words at the burying and the burying words at the wedding, and then he went home and slept like a child.

III. The Sale Barn

Wednesday

Tess Morin had come to Clay Hill four years before from Hartford, with a husband and two Nubian goats, and now she had twenty-two goats and was Lecturer of the Grange, which meant she planned the programs. She had joined because a Grange hall was the only

ROOM IN TOWN BIG ENOUGH TO TEACH A CHEESEMAKING class in, and she had stayed because she liked the old people more than she had expected to. She was thirty-one. She thought the Grange might live if somebody ran it right.

She and Arlene Fisk drove over to the sale barn on Wednesday afternoon to find the Master.

The Master was Sumner Corliss, Lyle's son. He was fifty-seven, and on Wednesdays he sold livestock from a little booth above the ring at the auction barn on the county road: cull cows, bob calves, feeder pigs, goats, lambs, rabbits in wire cages, once a camel. They sat in the bleachers and listened to him sell a Jersey cow with a bad quarter. He did not seem to breathe. The numbers went up out of him in a long rolling chant, and somewhere in the middle of it he would drop in three plain words for one man in the third row, *you know her, Walt,* and Walt would raise his card. Then the gavel, and the next one.

When the sale broke for coffee he came down the stairs, and they caught him by the scale.

Sumner, Arlene said. *We love your father.*

That's a bad start, said Sumner.

He read the Song of Solomon at Vernon's draping, said Tess. *The turtledoves. With Dot sitting right there. He read Job at Arlene's fiftieth. He prayed for the sick over a whole ring of steers. Every single time he gets up, he says the wrong thing, and he has no idea he's doing it. What is the point of having a chaplain who goes to a funeral and says the wedding?*

Sumner took his hat off and looked into it as if something might be written there.

It isn't the first time, he said. *He did the same thing at Pell Gladding's in 1981. That time it was worth sixteen oxen.*

The auction bell rang for the second half.

Supper's Saturday, he said. *I'll tell it then.*

IV. Three Bales

The burying ground on Clay Hill · May 1980

In 1980 Lyle Corliss had two Milking Devon oxen called Buck and Bright, red as a brick, with white horns tipped in black, and a hundred and ten acres of hardwood and ledge. He cut cordwood with them in the winter and twitched logs for the mill. In March they drew the sap sled through the sugarbush, and on Old Home Day they pulled the stoneboat for the children. They were nine years old. They had been in the yoke together since they were calves, Buck on the near side and Bright on the off, and they could not be worked any other way.

In April Buck swallowed a piece of baling wire with his hay. The vet came out and shook his head and it took Buck four days. Bright stood at the end of the tie-up looking at the empty stall and would not eat.

A trained ox was not a thing you could go buy. You could buy a pair of yearling steers and train them for three years, if you had three years, and if you had the money, and money that spring was at twenty percent at the bank in Concord. Lyle had neither. He hung the yoke on two pegs in the barn with one bow empty and worked Bright alone in a single harness, which an ox hates, and he lay awake.

His boy Sumner was fifteen that year. For two summers he had been ox-boy on the Gladding place over on the Hopkinton road.

Pell Gladding had made his money in a Boston investment house and bought the old Kimball farm when he retired, and he had put back everything the Kimballs had let fall: the long barn, the stone walls, the sugarhouse, the cupola with the copper ox on it. He kept a string of matched Devons in the barn, sixteen head, and showed them at the Hopkinton Fair on Labor Day weekend in a white shirt and a straw hat, and he had taken to Sumner from the first week. The boy could talk. He could talk to a steer that would not come up into the yoke and to a summer woman who wanted to pet one and to Gladding himself, at the end of a long day, about Daniel Webster and the price of hay. Gladding called him the Senator.

Ask Gladding for an ox, Lyle said at supper. *Just one. To go with Bright.*

Sumner looked at his plate. He thought: if I ask him, he'll think that was what I was working on all along. Two summers of being good company, and then the bill.

You ask him, he said.

All right, said Lyle. *You take me over.*

Sumner thought about his father in Gladding's kitchen. His father did not know how to come into a room. He came in with his cap on and his boots wet and said whatever was on top of his mind, and when the talk was over he did not know how to leave, and stood in the door. When it was time to say one thing he said another. Sumner loved him and was fifteen, and he decided to teach him.

On a Sunday evening in May he drove his father up to the old burying ground on Clay Hill. It sat in a square of stone wall at the top of the town road, and the first wives of Clay Hill had planted lilacs along the wall in seventeen-hundred-something, and the lilacs had gone on without them for two hundred years. They were in bloom. You could smell them from the road.

Sumner had brought three bales of hay in the back of the truck. He set them on end in the grass between the slate stones, a little apart, the way people stand in a kitchen.

This is Mr. Gladding, he said. *This one's Mr. Swett, who runs the barn for him. This one's Mrs. Gladding. Now. You take your cap off in the dooryard, not in the kitchen. You wipe your feet. You don't sit down till he tells you, and when he tells you, you still don't sit down, because you're asking for something. You say, Afternoon, Mr. Gladding. You nod to Mrs. Gladding. And then you say this.*

He had written it out on the back of a seed packet, four lines, so his father could say it like a piece at the Grange.

I had two oxen, Mr. Gladding,
and worked my woodlot with the pair.
But one of them is dead. I'd ask you,
if you'd let me, for another.

Lyle said it to the bales. He got it wrong. He said it again. The lilacs moved a little in the wind off Kearsarge, and the bales stood there and took it.

He practiced for a year. Sumner had not meant for it to take a year, but Lyle would not go until he had it perfect, and every time he thought he had it, it came out some other way. He went up to the burying ground in the evenings after chores, in haying and in the fall when the maples went red over the wall, and in the winter when the bales stood under caps of snow and he had to knock them off with his mitten so Mr. Gladding could hear him. He said it to them in mud season. Bright worked single all that year and got thin. In May the lilacs came out again, and Lyle stood in front of three gray, weathered bales and said all four lines, with his cap in his hand, without a mistake, and then said them again.

All right, said Sumner. *Saturday.*

V. The Kitchen

The Gladding place, Hopkinton road · May 1981

Sumner went over early, because Saturday was a workday for him, and took his place in the barn. Lyle came at two in his good gray shirt with a present, a quart of his own syrup from March in a glass jar with a Grange ribbon on it. He took his cap off in the dooryard. He wiped his feet.

Gladding was glad to see him. He came out of the kitchen with his reading glasses pushed up on his head and took Lyle's hand in both of his.

Lyle Corliss. You came all the way over the hill. Sit down, sit down. Ellen, it's the Senator's father. What can I do for you?

Mrs. Gladding was at the sink. Mr. Swett was at the table with the feed bills. Sumner had come in from the barn and stood by the door to the shed, where he always stood, and he saw that they were standing exactly where he had set the bales.

Lyle did not sit down. He stood in the middle of the kitchen with the cap in his hands, and said it.

I had two oxen, Mr. Gladding,
and worked my woodlot with the pair.

But one of them is dead. I'd ask you,
if you'd let me, take the other.

Gladding blinked.

Say that again, Lyle?

Lyle said it again, exactly as before, with great care, the way he had said it to the bales three hundred times. Take the other.

The kitchen clock ticked. Mr. Swett put his pencil down. Gladding looked at Lyle, who was waiting with his whole big body, and then he looked past him to the boy by the shed door, and he began to smile.

Senator, he said. *Sounds like you people have a barnful of oxen up on Clay Hill.*

Sumner did not have time to think, so he didn't.

Just as many as you've given us, Mr. Gladding.

Gladding laughed until he had to sit down himself. Mrs. Gladding laughed at the sink with her back to them. Mr. Swett did not laugh, because he had worked for Gladding for nine years and knew what was coming, and it came. Gladding was getting older and his heart was not what it had been, and he had been wondering for a year what to do with sixteen oxen he could no longer show. He wiped his eyes and gave them the sixteen. Eight yoke of Devons, matched, broke to the bow, with their yokes, their chains, the stoneboat and the sap sled. And because Lyle had said it so well, and because he had said it twice, he gave him the tenant house at Gladding's Corner, with forty acres along the brook, for one dollar, which Mr. Swett wrote up on the back of a feed bill.

They walked the oxen home that same evening, Lyle in front and Sumner behind with a goad, sixteen red cattle strung out two by two along the Hopkinton road and up over Clay Hill at a walk, with cars stopped behind them a mile back. People came out on their porches. It is still the thing anybody in Clay Hill over fifty will tell you about first, before the hurricane and before the year the mill burned: the night Lyle Corliss came home with sixteen oxen.

At the top of the hill they passed the burying ground. The three bales were still standing among the stones, and Lyle, who had led a yoke of

steers past them without looking, stopped the whole procession and took off his cap.

On the Monday he drove back over to thank Pell Gladding properly. He stood in the dooryard and shook his hand and told him he was sorry for his trouble.

VI. The Bean Supper

Clay Hill Grange hall · December 2022

Sumner told it on the Saturday at the bean supper, standing by the kitchen pass-through with a dish towel over his shoulder, between the beans and the pie. There were baked beans, yellow-eye and pea beans both, brown bread out of the can, coleslaw, red hot dogs and eleven pies. Lyle sat at the end of the long table under the Christmas lights the Fisks' granddaughter had never taken down, and when Sumner got to the kitchen and the words changed places, Lyle laughed louder than anybody. He had heard it told a hundred times. He liked it best of all the stories about himself.

Gladding was the king of this town, as far as I knew then, Sumner said. *Dad was Dad. I was the boy who did the talking. I've been doing it ever since, on Wednesdays, for two percent.*

Tess Morin was sitting across from Lyle. She had heard the story about the sixteen oxen before, from three different people, but never with the bales in it, and never the part about the year.

So he hasn't changed, she said.

No, said Sumner. *He hasn't learned a thing since 1981. Not one word.* He said it gently, and he looked down the table at his father, who was eating pie, and said the rest of it to him, as if they were alone in the barn.

> *Man that is in honor, and understandeth not, Is like the beasts that perish.*
>
> *— Psalm 49:20*

Gladding's oxen got bigger every year I knew them, he said. *Bigger and stronger and redder. That's what an ox does. Never got a bit smarter. They were the best things we ever had on the place.*

Lyle nodded with his mouth full. *That's so,* he said.

Arlene Fisk laughed. Dot Hatch, at the far end, laughed too, the way she had at the draping, with her hand over her eyes. Tess did not laugh. She was looking at Lyle Corliss's big ruined hands on the oilcloth, and thinking of a man standing in a burying ground for a year, in all weathers, talking to three bales of hay so that he could ask for one ox properly, and then asking for the wrong thing in front of the king. Something in her that had been keeping a list let go of the list. She took out the Lecturer's notebook and wrote down the verse and the number of it, and under it, *sixteen,* and underlined it.

At eight o'clock the Master asked the chaplain to say the grace for the close of the meal.

Lyle stood up, which took a while. Fifty people bowed their heads over the wreck of eleven pies.

Bless this food, he said, *which we are about to receive.*

Amen, said Clay Hill Grange.

In the barn on Clay Hill, where Lyle still kept a pair of Devon steers at eighty-four because he did not know how to live without them, the old yoke from 1980 hung on its two pegs above the tie-up, one bow worn bright from Bright's neck and the other one empty, and nobody had ever taken it down.

Background

The verse

> *A man who has learnt little, grows old like an ox; his flesh grows, but his knowledge does not grow.*
>
> Dhammapada 152, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the monk Lāḷudāyi always says the wrong thing. He recites funeral verses at festivals and verses of blessing at funerals, and he never notices. The

Buddha tells the monks it is not the first time. In a past life, the Brahmin Aggidatta lost one of his two oxen. His son Somadatta was a favorite of the king and would not ask the king for an ox himself, so he coached his slow father in a charnel ground called the Fragrant Bush, with bundles of grass set up to stand for the king and his officers. The father practiced the request for a year, and then asked the king to take his other ox. Somadatta saved the moment with a quick answer, and the king, pleased, gave sixteen oxen and a village. The father was Lāḷudāyi, the king was Ānanda and the son was the Buddha himself. Read the full commentary story.

Clay Hill (fictional), Merrimack County, New Hampshire

New Hampshire hill towns, 1980–2022

The Grange (the Order of Patrons of Husbandry) was founded in 1867. Its ritual and its seven degrees borrow from Freemasonry, and many rural towns still have a Grange hall. Each local Grange elects officers who include a chaplain and three Graces, Ceres, Pomona and Flora. Among the chaplain's duties is the charter-draping ceremony for a member who has died. Grange membership fell by forty percent between 1992 and 2007. In 2022 the National Grange reported its first net gain in almost seven decades, some of it from young farmers and homesteaders. Rural New Hampshire also keeps its Old Home Days, which go back to the Old Home Week begun by Governor Frank W. Rollins at the turn of the twentieth century to call home the sons and daughters who had left for the West.

Devon cattle came to New England with the Pilgrims from 1623 and were long the region's working oxen. They are red, with white horns tipped black. The old dairy-and-draft line, now called the Milking Devon, is rare enough to be listed as critical. An ox is a trained steer of four years or more. The teamster walks on the left, and each animal learns its side, near or off, so that a partner is hard to replace (a New Hampshire teamster explains). Ox teams still show and pull at fairs such as the Hopkinton State Fair, held since 1915. In 1980 the Federal Reserve's fight against inflation pushed interest rates to about twenty percent, the start of the 1980s farm crisis.

The common lilac, planted in dooryards and burying grounds across the state, has been New Hampshire's state flower since 1919.

After the story of the Elder Lāḷudāyi from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 152). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

11.8

Third Sunrise

Till thou at length art free,
Leaving thine outgrown shell by life's unresting sea!
— Oliver Wendell Holmes, "The Chambered Nautilus" (1858)

This is the pass-down as I got it, at the big pool on Space Center Boulevard.

I. The Question

Clear Lake, Texas · 2024

Andy had been a diver at the pool for twenty-two years, and for eighteen of them he had worked June Tolliver's classes. He set up her mockups and carried her checklists, and he hung in the water beside her students with a hand on their boots. He remembered everything she had ever said in a debrief. When two instructors disagreed about how Tolliver had taught a thing, they went and asked Andy, and he gave it back to them in her words. So when the history office wanted her on tape, she said she would talk to him and to nobody else.

They sat in her kitchen with the recorder between them. She was sixty-six. On the third afternoon he took a printout from his bag. It was the loop transcript from her second spacewalk, in 2002, when the station's arm was a year old.

There's a line here nobody has ever explained, he said. *Phased elapsed time four hours fifty-one. You'd been hanging on the end of the arm for three revs. Then this.*

EV1 There you are. I see you. You're all done.

CAPCOM EV1, Houston. Say again?

EV1 Disregard, Houston. I've got sunrise.

Who were you talking to?

She looked at the page for a while. In twenty-two years nobody had asked her.

II. The Hold

Low Earth orbit · 2002

She was a framing carpenter's daughter from Coos Bay, Oregon. That morning she was two hundred and forty miles up, on her way out to the end of a new girder to drive bolts. Her boots were locked in the foot restraint at the end of the arm. Okada was flying it from inside and swinging her out over the lab, and Hendry was somewhere behind her on the truss with the cable bag. Then the arm stopped.

It stopped so smoothly that it took her a second to notice. Then Okada said a word in Japanese, and Houston came on. The arm's computer had safed itself and set the brakes. They would have to bring up the backup string from the ground, and they wanted several passes to do it carefully. Hendry asked if he should go out and get her. Houston said negative. Hendry was to press on with the cables, and EV1 was in a good config where she was. *June, you're go to hang out.*

There was nothing within reach of her but the arm. She had the planet under her boots and the sun on her left shoulder, and about nine minutes of daylight.

The voice arrived at once. Every astronaut has it and nobody talks about it. It told her that she had no business in that seat. Thousands of people had applied the year she got in, and it could name the ones who ought to be standing here. It said the arm had quit because of something she had done. It told her to key the mike and say she was uncomfortable, so that Hendry would be sent to walk her home, and that would be the end of it, and nobody would blame her much. When she did not key the mike it threw things. A torn glove. A tether hook left open. Her father's face when they phoned him. Each one came at her fast, and she let each come the whole way in. When they got to her there was nothing in them.

Then it asked what right she had to stay.

Her right hand was free. She put it out in front of her with the palm down, toward the Earth. Everyone who had ever fed her was down there, and everyone who had taught her or told her no. The Earth did not say anything. The voice had no more to say either.

The dark came across the Pacific at seventeen thousand miles an hour and went over her. She reached up and switched off her helmet lights.

III. First Night

The first pass through the shadow

WITH THE LIGHTS OFF SHE COULD NOT SEE HER OWN GLOVES. She began to remember.

It did not come the way memory usually does, in scraps. She remembered in order, and each time she was all the way inside it. She was nine and sitting on a roof deck in Coos Bay with a coffee can of sixteenpenny nails between her knees. Her name there was Junebug. She ate Fig Newtons and wanted her father to look at her. Then she was at Oregon State with a slide rule on her belt, and then she was at a desk in Renton doing wing loads. At that desk her name was Tolliver and she ate out of a machine. She wanted the corner office, and when she had it she wanted Houston. She had a husband in one of those lives. After that she was in the back seat of a T-38, and after that she was on her first flight. She had been certain every time that this one was the life. Each time she had moved in and set out her things, and then she had left without looking back at the one before.

She knew what it was like. Her grandmother had kept half a nautilus shell on top of the sewing machine. It was sawn through so that you could see the rooms. When June was thirteen she won a speech ribbon reciting the poem that went with it, and she still had all of it.

Year after year beheld the silent toil
That spread his lustrous coil;
Still, as the spiral grew,
He left the past year's dwelling for the new,
Stole with soft step its shining archway through,
Built up its idle door,
Stretched in his last-found home, and knew the old no more.

— Oliver Wendell Holmes, "The Chambered Nautilus"

She had always taken that as praise of the animal.

Then the remembering went on past where it should have stopped. She was on a roof again, in 1946, and the hands holding the hammer were her father's. She was in a kitchen in a sod house with a woman whose name she had never been told, and she knew what that woman had wanted. It went back further than she could count, and she did not try to count. In every one of them there was a name and a meal and a wanting, and then a move to the next.

The sun came up on her right like a welding arc. She had been in the dark for thirty-four minutes.

IV. Second Night

The second pass

She spent the daylight watching Hendry's helmet go back and forth along the truss. Houston said the backup string was looking good and to give them one more rev. She said copy. When the shadow came over the second time she left her lights off and looked down.

She was a structures engineer and she did not have a word for the way she saw that night. She could see the storms over the Congo lit from inside like paper lanterns. The squid fleets in the Gulf of Thailand were green, and the Nile was a lit stem with a flower at the end of it. She had seen all of that before on her first flight. This time she could see the people too. She did not see them as dots. She saw each one, the way you see a face across a table. They were arriving and leaving the whole time.

A light came on in a window in Karachi because a child had been born under it, and a light went off in Omaha. Nobody was put anywhere. Each one went on to the next place by what they had done and what they had wanted, the way water goes downhill. She saw a man who had been cruel for sixty years go where that went, and a woman who had fed strangers go where that went. She watched it for half an hour and nobody told her what it meant. It was like being shown how a truss carries a load.

A meteor burned out below her, between her boots and the sea.

V. Third Night

The third pass · elapsed time 4:17 to 4:51

By the third dark her feet were cold and her mind was clear, and she did what she had been trained to do with a failure. She ran the chain.

Why was she on this arm? Because she had been assigned the flight. She had the flight because she had wanted it and had worked eleven years to get it. She had wanted it because the first flight had been so sweet that the day she landed she was already hungry. And the first flight was sweet because of a July night when she was eleven, when her father pointed a hammer at the moon and said there were men walking on that, Junebug. That night had felt a certain way in her chest. The feeling came from seeing, and the seeing came from having eyes and a mind turned toward it, and that came from being born. She had been born because somebody before her had wanted something too. She could not find a place where it began.

Then she ran it the other direction, the way you check a load path. If there is no wanting, the next house does not get framed. And without the next house there is nobody who has to move into it, and furnish it, and stand in the door of it afraid.

She saw then that she had been wrong about one thing all her life. She had thought she was the tenant. In every one of those rooms she had believed she was the one who lived there. But there was a builder, and it

had been the same builder every time. Its face was so familiar to her that she had never once looked straight at it.

She looked at it now.

Her father used to say that a roof is all one piece of wanting to fall down, and the ridge is what talks it out of it. If you pull the ridge, the rafters lie down by themselves. She watched them lie down. Ahead of her the edge of the world drew a blue line and then a gold one, and the sun came over.

She spoke out loud, because there was somebody to tell. Houston asked her to say again.

VI. The Answer

Clear Lake · the same afternoon

THAT'S WHO, SHE SAID. *THE BUILDER. I'D BEEN LOOKING FOR HIM my whole life without knowing I was looking. I kept getting born into the next thing and it kept hurting. Once I'd seen him he couldn't get a rafter to stand.*

Andy checked that the recorder was running.

You want the rest of the poem, she said. *Everybody learned it as a poem about self-improvement.*

> *Build thee more stately mansions, O my soul,*
> *As the swift seasons roll!*
> *Leave thy low-vaulted past!*
> *Let each new temple, nobler than the last,*
> *Shut thee from heaven with a dome more vast,*
> *Till thou at length art free,*
> *Leaving thine outgrown shell by life's unresting sea!*
>
> *— Oliver Wendell Holmes, "The Chambered Nautilus"*

He has it in the last two lines. I spent forty-four years on the first five. Every one of those domes shuts you in, Andy, and it doesn't matter how big you build it. That was mine, she said, and tipped her head back, as though the helmet were still there.

And then what?

Then the arm came back. Okada flew me out to the end and I drove my bolts, and we went in. It was a good EVA.

The next winter *Columbia* was lost and nobody flew for two and a half years. By the time the line moved again she had asked the office to take her name off it. People assumed it was fear, and she let them. She went over to the pool and stayed eighteen years. She taught spacewalkers one thing that was not in any flight rule. Sometime in every run she would stop the task and have them hang where they were, with their lights off, until whatever was talking to them had finished.

You never put in for another flight, Andy said.

There wasn't anybody left who wanted to go.

• • •

He teaches the class now. The pool is forty feet deep and holds six million gallons, with a station lying on the bottom of it. On a Tuesday in the fall he had two new ones on the mockup arm, with their boots in the restraints and safety divers at their heels. Two hours in, he keyed the loop and told them to stop work and kill their helmet lights. Then he told them what she had said on the third sunrise, word for word, and he let the clock run.

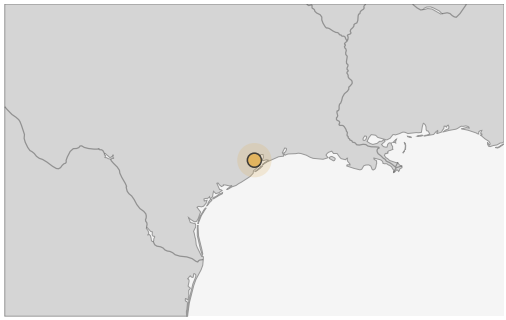
Background

The verses

> *Looking for the maker of this tabernacle, I shall have to run through a course of many births, so long as I do not find (him); and painful is birth again and again. But now, maker of the tabernacle, thou hast been seen; thou shalt not make up this tabernacle again. All thy rafters are broken, thy ridge-pole is sundered; the mind, approaching the Eternal (visankhara, nirvana), has attained to the extinction of all desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 153–154, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

These two verses are traditionally the first words the Buddha spoke after his awakening. The commentary's account is brief. Sitting at the foot of the Bodhi tree, he over-

came Māra before sunset. In the first watch of the night he recalled his former lives. In the middle watch he gained the divine eye, which sees beings passing away and arising according to their deeds. In the last watch he worked through dependent origination forwards and backwards, and at sunrise he was awake and spoke the verses. The "builder of the house" is craving. Much later he recited the verses to his attendant Ānanda, who had asked. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda, who is remembered for his memory, and the Bodhi tree.



Low Earth orbit and Clear Lake (Houston), Texas

Orbit and Houston, 2002 and after

June Tolliver, her crew and her spacewalk are invented, and the story names no real flight. The setting is real. The International Space Station circles the Earth about every ninety-two minutes, so a crew sees some sixteen sunrises a day, and a spacewalk of six or seven hours passes through several orbital nights of roughly half an hour each. Spacewalkers wear the Extravehicular Mobility Unit, whose helmet carries its own lights. The lead spacewalker is called EV1 and the astronaut in Mission Control who talks to the crew is CAPCOM. The station's robotic arm, Canadarm2, arrived in April 2001. It can carry an astronaut in a foot restraint at its tip, and its trouble in this story is made up. *Columbia* was lost on February 1, 2003, and shuttles did not fly again until July 2005.

Astronauts rehearse spacewalks underwater at the Neutral Buoyancy Laboratory near the Johnson Space Center, a pool 202 feet long and 40 feet deep that holds 6.2 million gallons and full-size station mockups, where safety divers attend each suited trainee. The center's Oral History Project has recorded interviews with its people since 1996. Oliver Wendell Holmes Sr., physician and professor of anatomy, published "The Chambered Nautilus" in *The Autocrat of the Breakfast-Table* in 1858. Generations of American schoolchildren learned it by heart. The nautilus adds a new chamber to its shell as it grows and seals off the old one behind it.

After the story of the exalted utterances spoken to the Elder Ānanda, from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 153 and 154). The original. Verses from Oliver Wendell Holmes, "The Chambered Nautilus" (1858). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

II.9

The Lily Pond

> *I am become like a pelican in the wilderness, and like an owl that is in the desert.*
> *— Psalm 102:6*

This is what I heard, on Asylum Hill.

I. Trebles

Asylum Hill, Hartford · 1898

Hiram Holbrook made steel tubing for bicycle frames in a brick works on Capitol Avenue, and in the spring of 1897, when every clerk in Hartford rode to the office on two wheels and the craze looked as if it would never end, he sold the works for a sum the *Courant* printed on its front page and never went down to Capitol Avenue again. He was forty-four. He bought eleven acres on the slope west of Prospect Avenue, with a carriage house and a stand of elms. At the bottom of the lawn there was a hollow, and his wife had it dug out into a pond, planted with white water lilies, and stocked with goldfish from a dealer in Boston.

Then he and Abigail sat down in the library to decide what their son should learn.

There was very little, they agreed, that the boy would need. There was money in that house for three lifetimes. He would not have to sell anything or make anything or answer to anyone. Let him have what his father had never had time for. Abigail, who came from Litchfield people and had the Litchfield sort of conscience, made one condition. On his tenth birthday Dana signed a printed card at her desk, promising, God helping

him, never to touch intoxicating drink, and she put the card in her Bible at the Book of Proverbs and that was the end of his moral instruction.

After that he learned to sing.

He had a voice. Everybody said so. Walter Ince said so, and Walter Ince did not say things. He had come over that autumn from Lichfield, in England, where he had been a cathedral chorister and then a pupil of the organist, to be organist and choirmaster at St. Barnabas on Farmington Avenue. He was twenty-two and thin as a music stand. At the first rehearsal he walked down the front row of trebles in their Eton collars with his head on one side, the way a man listens to a watch, and stopped at the Holbrook boy and held up his hand, and the whole choir stopped with it.

Again, he said. *You alone.*

Dana sang the Mendelssohn solo, *O for the wings of a dove*, at Evensong four Easters running. Women in the parish wept into their gloves. Mr. Ince never praised it. He said *Breathe* and *Lower* and *Again*, and once, after a Christmas when the boy had held the last note longer than was written, *That was for you. Next time make it for them.*

He had piano lessons twice a week from a German on Asylum Street, and a banjo from a man who played on the excursion boats down the river. He was not sent to learn bookkeeping, or Latin past the second year, or anything about steel. When his voice broke at fourteen he cried for two days, and Mr. Ince took him into the vestry and played a low C on the harmonium and told him to match it. *It will come back lower,* he said. *Wait.* It came back a baritone, warm and easy, and Dana took it to Yale in 1906 and sang in the Glee Club and in the late quartets at Mory's, where the other boys drank beer out of silver cups and he drank ginger ale, because of the card in the Bible, and was the only one who could still find the pitch at one in the morning.

Celia Burnham's grandfather had founded a fire insurance company, and her people had arrived at the same conclusion Dana's had, by the same road. Celia learned to dance. She learned the waltz and the two-step from a dancing master on Pearl Street before she could do long division, and later ballet from a Russian in New York she went down to by train, and what was called aesthetic dancing, in a Greek tunic, barefoot

on the lawn of the Golf Club for a pageant. She held her head as though there were a book on it. She could cross a ballroom without seeming to touch the floor.

They were married at St. Barnabas in June of 1912. Mr. Ince played them out with the Widor, too loud, which everyone forgave him. Hiram Holbrook died in 1915. Abigail died in October of 1918, of the influenza, in three days. Celia's mother and father followed inside of a year. When the lawyers were done there was twice the money in the one house on the slope, and nobody in it who had ever been taught to count it.

II. Prospect Street

Downtown Hartford · 1920

Dana went down to the Hartford Club three times a day, the way his father had. At ten for the mail and the New York papers. At one for lunch. At five for the hour before dinner, when the men came over from the insurance companies and somebody always asked him to sit down at the piano. Fenn drove him in the Pierce-Arrow, down Farmington Avenue and through the city to Prospect Street, and waited at the curb with the motor ticking, across from the new Travelers Tower, which was the tallest thing in New England and which Dana had watched go up from the club window one floor at a time.

In January of 1920 the country went dry. Connecticut had never agreed to it. The state senate had voted the amendment down. It came anyway, and with it came a new kind of man on the sidewalks of downtown Hartford, men who lived by their wits and had found that their wits were suddenly worth a great deal.

Four of them took to waiting on the iron fence across from the club. A Kerryman named Duffy, who had worked the boats out of New London. A piano player who had lost his job at a hotel bar when there were no more hotel bars. Two others whose names changed. They watched which car came at ten, and at one, and at five, and who got out of it, and who touched his hat to him.

On a cold bright morning in March they were ready. They had flasks in their coat pockets, and salted peanuts in paper twists, and horehound candy, and a paper of hot sausage from the cart at the corner, and a bunch of scallions that Duffy bit the ends off of and chewed like a horse. When the Pierce-Arrow pulled up they started in on all of it, loudly, with a great show of pleasure, passing the flasks, and when Dana stepped out onto the curb Duffy lifted his and called across the street.

Long life to you, Mr. Holbrook! A hundred years! And may the four of us eat and drink on you the whole of it!

Dana laughed. He liked to be liked. He stood on the curb with his gloves in his hand.

Fenn, he said, *what are they drinking?*

Something, sir.

Is it good?

Fenn had been in France. He looked at the four men on the fence for a while before he answered.

Mr. Holbrook, there isn't anything in this world like it.

Well, then, said Dana. *I ought to know what it is.*

Fenn crossed the street and came back with a little in the cap of Duffy's flask. Dana drank it on the curb with his back to the club windows. It was Canadian, and good, and it went down into him like the first warm day. He sent Fenn back for a little more. That evening he did not go home for dinner until after nine, and Celia, who had been taught never to ask a man where he had been, did not ask.

The card was still in Abigail's Bible in the library, at Proverbs. Nobody had opened the Bible since the funeral.

III. The Ready Tin

Hartford and New Haven · 1920–1931

IT TOOK DUFFY ABOUT A MONTH TO SEE THAT IT HAD BECOME a habit, and after that the four of them were never far away. Then they were eight. Then there were more of them than Dana could have named, though he knew them all by their faces and always had a word for each.

There was a back room on Front Street behind an Italian grocer's, and a room over a garage on Allyn Street, and later a house in the Farmington Valley with the shades down. Wherever he was, he got into the way of pulling a roll of bills out of his coat and setting it on the card table in front of him, and then another roll, and peeling them off as the evening went.

Fenn, take this and get flowers for the table. Take this and get the good cigars, not those. Look at this one, he can make the dice do anything he tells them. Listen to this man play! Have you ever heard anything like that? Give him a thousand. This one can do the Charleston, look at him go. Give him two.

Late, he would sit down at whatever piano there was and sing. He still had the voice. He sang the old Glee Club songs and the new ones off the records, and near the end of every night, because they asked for it, the Kipling song they used to do at Mory's, about the gentlemen who had come down in the world and gone into the ranks as common soldiers. The whole room would come in on the line they all knew, roaring it, pounding the tables.

> *And the world was more than kin while he held the ready tin,*
> *But to-day the Sergeant's something less than kind.*
>
> *— Rudyard Kipling, "Gentlemen-Rankers" (1892)*

Dana sang it laughing, with his head thrown back, and did not hear a word of it.

He put money into a musical revue that tried out at the Shubert in New Haven and closed there. He put money into a speedboat, and a racing stable in Kentucky he never saw, and a man who said he could get whiskey across the border in hollow telephone poles. He paid for weddings and funerals of people whose last names he never learned. He bought a band its instruments. It went out of him the way water goes out of a basin with the stopper pulled, smoothly, with a little turning motion at the end, and he did not look down at it until the spring of 1926, when Duffy, who by then was something like a secretary, came to him at the club and shut the door.

Mr. Holbrook, I'm sorry to tell you. It's gone. All of yours.

Dana thought about that for a while with his drink in his hand.

Has my wife no money?

She has, sir. A good deal.

Well, then, said Dana. *Fetch that.*

Celia signed the papers at the dining-room table where she had been taught to sit up straight. She had been taught to follow. She had followed in the waltz and in the two-step and in the long marriage, beautifully, and she followed now, and signed where the lawyer's finger was, and her grandfather's fire insurance money went the same way as the bicycle money, onto card tables, into bands and boats and telephone poles. By the time the market broke in 1929 there was not much left of it for the market to take.

IV. Everything

West Hartford · 1931–1940

THEN HE SOLD THINGS.

He sold the farm in Simsbury, where the shade tobacco grew under white cloth in the summers like a field of tents. He sold the cottage at Fenwick with Celia's rose garden. He sold the Pierce-Arrow and then the Packard he had bought to replace it, and let Fenn go with two weeks' wages and a gold watch, which Fenn tried to give back. He sold the Gorham silver, and the Haviland china a few pieces at a time to a dealer on Pratt Street, all of it but one cup with a gold rim and a small chip, which Celia kept back without saying so. He sold his grandmother's quilts and the down comforters and Celia's sealskin coat and the chesterfield from the library and the library, shelf by shelf. Abigail's Bible went in a box of books for a dollar, and the card went with it, still at Proverbs.

The Steinway went last. Two men came with a dolly and took off the legs in the front hall and carried it out on its side like a coffin. Dana stood in the empty music room and hummed a note and listened to it come back off the bare walls.

In September of 1938 the hurricane came up the river and took down the elms along the drive, nine of them, and there was no money to have them cut. They lay across the drive all that winter with their roots in the air. The goldfish in the lily pond had grown as long as a man's hand and nobody fed them but the herons that came up from the river in the fall and stood at the edge on one leg and fed themselves.

In the spring of 1940 he sold the house. A builder named Gorski bought it, house and lawn and pond, and let them stay on until the papers passed, and then on a Monday in May his men came and carried their trunks to the curb and changed the locks. In the carriage house, behind the harness pegs, one of them found a boy's lemonwood archery bow with a broken limb and a quiver with two arrows left in it, and asked Dana if he wanted them, and Dana said no.

They took a room on Sigourney Street, back on Asylum Hill, six blocks from St. Barnabas. It was in what Hartford called a perfect six, three floors of yellow brick with two bow fronts and six families, and their room was the one behind the kitchen of the family on the third floor, so that every time they went out or came in they went through somebody else's kitchen and said good evening. They lived against other people's walls. They heard other people's radios and fights and children through every one of them.

By the war Dana was singing for money. He stood at the corner of Main and Asylum with his hat off, or in front of G. Fox's at Christmas when the windows were lit, and sang carols and the old Glee Club songs in a baritone that was still better than anything else on Main Street, and Celia stood beside him in a cloth coat holding out the Haviland cup. People put dimes in it. Some of them remembered who he was. Those did not stop.

After a while they were eating what people left. The kitchen door of the Bond Hotel. The back of a cafeteria on Pearl Street. And on Thursday nights the alley behind the parish house of St. Barnabas, where the women of the Auxiliary had their supper before choir practice and whatever was left went out the kitchen door in the boys' hands.

V. The Kitchen Door

St. Barnabas, Farmington Avenue · October 1948

Practice let out at half past eight. The trebles came clattering down the parish house stairs with their cassocks over their arms and went straight to the kitchen, because the Auxiliary ladies gave them the pans to carry out, and it was the part of Thursday they liked best. Creamed chicken in a roasting pan. A basket of rolls under a dish towel. A coffee pot with the grounds still in it. Out in the alley, under the light over the kitchen door, there were four or five men waiting, and a woman, and the boys went down the line and spooned it into whatever was held out to them. Pails. Coffee cans. A pie tin. A china cup with a gold rim.

Walter Ince came out the vestry door with his music case. He was seventy-two. He had been at St. Barnabas for fifty years that autumn and the vestry had given him a dinner and a silver salver and a pension he had not asked for. He was still thin, and he still held his head on one side.

He stopped on the vestry step and looked at the alley.

Kenneth Lusk, who was twelve and the head chorister and stood at the end of the front row on the Decani side, was coming back with the empty chicken pan, and he saw Mr. Ince standing in the light from the kitchen window, looking at the old man with the china cup. And he saw Mr. Ince smile.

It was not a large smile. Kenneth knew all of Mr. Ince's faces, the way boys learn the faces of the one person whose opinion they cannot do without, and he had seen this one only a few times. It was the face Mr. Ince made when a boy came in a beat early, at the very top of a phrase, so that everybody heard it. It was not unkind. It was not surprised.

Kenneth took the pan in and came back out. Mr. Ince was still on the step.

Sir, Kenneth said, *why did you smile?*

Mr. Ince did not answer right away. He came down the step and walked Kenneth along the side of the church toward the avenue, where

Kenneth's mother would be waiting in the Plymouth, and at the corner he stopped.

Do you know who that is?

No, sir.

That is Dana Holbrook. He stood where you stand. Decani, the end of the front row. He sang the Mendelssohn four Easters running, better than you will, and you will sing it well. He looked back toward the alley. *He had more money than anyone in this parish. His wife had nearly as much. They had the house on the hill past Prospect, with the pond.*

Kenneth waited. He had learned that if you waited Mr. Ince would go on, and if you said anything he would not.

If he had put his hand to anything at all when he was twenty-five, Mr. Ince said, *anything, his father's trade or anyone's, there would not be a richer man in Hartford today. If he had started at forty-five, he would be the second. If he had started at fifty, when they still had the roof over them, he would be the third. And she would have had all of it with him.*

He shifted the music case to his other hand.

And if he had given it to God. At twenty-five, Kenneth, he would have been a saint. I mean that. I heard what was in him. And Celia would have been the next thing to one, because she goes where she is led. At forty-five, a holy man, and she a good woman. At fifty, at the very least, a man at peace, and she would have had her peace. He was given every one of those, one after another, and he let every one of them go by. Now he has neither the one nor the other.

Then Mr. Ince said the psalm, the way he pointed the psalms for the boys on Thursdays, quietly, with the small lift at the half-verse where the star is printed in the Prayer Book.

> *I am become like a pelican in the wilderness, and like an owl that is in the desert.*
>
> *For I have eaten ashes as it were bread, and mingled my drink with weeping;*
>
> *And that, because of thine indignation and wrath; for thou hast taken me up, and cast me down.*
>
> *My days are gone like a shadow, and I am withered like grass.*
>
> *— Psalm 102:6, 9–11*

Kenneth looked back down the alley. The old man had finished the chicken and was holding the china cup for his wife while she ate the roll, and he had his other hand on the small of her back, as if they were about to go out onto a floor together.

He still has his voice, Kenneth said. *I've heard him by G. Fox's.*

Yes, said Mr. Ince. *That is what was left to him. It is the only thing anyone ever taught him.*

Kenneth's mother tapped the horn. Mr. Ince put his hand on the boy's head for a moment, which he had never done before, and went back up the side of the church toward the vestry, and Kenneth got into the Plymouth and did not say anything all the way home to Elizabeth Street.

That night he did his Latin. He did it every night after that, all through school, and could not have told anyone why, and nobody asked.

VI. The Pond

West Hartford · November 1948

On the first Sunday in November, with the dimes from the week, they took the bus out Farmington Avenue. Celia had wanted to for a long time and Dana had not, and then one morning he put on his hat and said, *All right.*

The elms were gone. Mr. Gorski had put a road up the middle of the lawn where the drive had been, and paved it, and named it Holbrook Road, and on either side of it there were eleven Cape Cod houses with

dormers and picture windows and young maples staked in the front yards, and in the driveways the cars of men who had been in the Pacific and the Bulge and now sold insurance downtown. The big house had been cut up into apartments. Somebody had painted the shutters green.

At the bottom of the road, where the lawn had gone down into the hollow, there was the pond. Gorski had drained it in the summer to fill it for two more lots, and had not got to the filling. The bulldozer stood at the edge with frost on its seat. The lily roots were heaped on the bank, black and fibrous, the size of a man's arm. The bed of the pond had dried and cracked into plates like a broken platter, and in the low middle there was a skin of brown water an inch deep that had already started to freeze at the rim.

A heron was standing in it.

It was a great blue, tall as a child, and it stood in the middle of the dead pond on one leg with its neck drawn down into its shoulders, the way the herons had stood at the edge of the lilies every autumn of their marriage, when the goldfish were fat and gold and slow. It did not fly when they came down the bank. It turned its head and looked at them with one yellow eye and turned it back to the water.

A boy from one of the new houses was poking along the bank with a stick. He had pulled something out of the mud and was looking at it, and when he saw them he held it up. It was an arrow, the shaft black with rot, the feathers gone, the little brass point gone green.

Hey, mister. Look what was in the pond.

Dana looked at it a long time. Then he said it was a fine one and the boy should keep it, and the boy ran up the hill with it to show somebody.

Celia stood on the bank with her hands in the pockets of the cloth coat. Dana stood next to her. After a while he began, very quietly, to sing. It was not one of the Glee Club songs. It was a psalm to the chant he had learned at ten, on a Thursday, with Walter Ince walking down the front row with his head on one side, and he had not sung it in forty years and had every word.

> *I have considered the days of old, and the years that are past.*
>
> *I call to remembrance my song, and in the night I commune with mine own heart, and search out my spirit.*
>
> *— Psalm 77:5–6*

His voice was still good. It carried across the cracked mud to the bulldozer and came back off its blade. A woman in one of the picture windows stopped with a dish in her hand and listened, and did not know what it was.

The heron did not look up. It put its bill down into the brown water and brought it up with nothing, and waited, and put it down again.

Background

The verses

> *Men who have not observed proper discipline, and have not gained treasure in their youth, perish like old herons in a lake without fish.*
>
> Dhammapada 155, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Men who have not observed proper discipline, and have not gained treasure in their youth, lie, like broken bows, sighing after the past.*
>
> Dhammapada 156, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Mahā Dhana ("Great Wealth") is the son of a rich family in Bārāṇasī whose parents, thinking he would never need anything else, have him taught only singing and music; his wife, from an equally rich house, is taught only dancing. When both sets of parents die, the couple hold a double fortune. Rogues who watch the road he takes three times a day to the king's palace sit drinking and eating where he can see them, and toast him; he asks his attendant what they are drinking, is told nothing in the world compares to it, and takes a little, then more. Surrounded by hangers-on, he spends his own fortune and then his wife's, sells his fields, parks, carriages, dishes and coverlets, and finally the family house, from which the new owners put him out. In old age he and his wife live against other people's walls and he begs with a broken bowl, eating leftovers handed out by novices at a rest-house. The Buddha, seeing him there, smiles, and tells Ānanda that had Mahā Dhana applied himself in youth, middle age or old age he would have been the first, second or third richest man in the city, and had he gone forth he would have reached

the paths of holiness, his wife a step behind him; instead he has lost both, like a heron in a dried-up pond. Read the full commentary story, or about the Dhammapada and its commentary.

Hartford, Connecticut

Hartford, 1897–1948

At the end of the nineteenth century Hartford was a manufacturing city as well as an insurance one: the Pope Manufacturing Company made Columbia bicycles there from 1878, and owned its own steel-tubing plants in the city, before the bicycle trade gave way to the automobile. The Hartford Club, founded in 1873, has met since 1908 in its clubhouse on Prospect Street, across from the Travelers Tower, which was the tallest building in New England from its completion in 1919 until 1964 (Travelers Tower). When national Prohibition came in January 1920, Connecticut was one of only two states that had refused to ratify it; its senate voted the amendment down, enforcement in the state was thin, and liquor came ashore from the "rum row" of ships anchored off the coast (Connecticut Digital Newspaper Project). The "perfect six," a three-story apartment house with two bow fronts and six flats, was a Hartford type built in large numbers on Asylum Hill and elsewhere early in the century (Historic Buildings of Connecticut).

After the Second World War, West Hartford filled up with new houses for returning veterans and their families; its population grew by more than fifteen thousand in the two decades after 1940, and the war-workers' housing built there in 1942–43 became the subject of a long fight over who could live in it (Life in West Hartford). The psalms in the story are from the Psalter of the American Book of Common Prayer of 1928, which was essentially Miles Coverdale's sixteenth-century translation (the 1928 Psalter); choirs sang it to Anglican chant, with an asterisk marking the half-verse. The Kipling song is "Gentlemen-Rankers" from *Barrack-Room Ballads* (1892), sung at Harvard and Yale in the early 1900s and adapted there into the Whiffenpoof Song (Gentleman ranker).

After the story of Mahā Dhana, the rich man's son, from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 155 and 156). The original. Scripture from the Psalter of the Book of Common Prayer (1928); song from Rudyard Kipling, *Barrack-Room Ballads* (1892). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 12

Self

12.1

One Watch

> *Except the LORD build the house, they labour in vain that build it: except the LORD keep the city, the watchman waketh but in vain.*
> *— Psalm 127:1*

This is the way it was told to me, on the Currituck Banks.

I. Redhead

The Currituck Banks, North Carolina · summer 1902

ELLIS TILLETT BUILT HIS HOUSE ON THE MARSH WHERE nobody had ever thought to build anything, on the sound side of the Banks north of the Narrows, and when it was done it looked as if it were floating.

He had it set on juniper pilings driven twenty feet into the mud, so the whole of it stood a man's height clear of the marsh grass, and at high water with the wind out of the south the sound came in under it and there was nothing beneath the house but light on water. It had three stories and a cupola. It had copper gutters, cypress shingles, a porch that went all the way around, and a dining room paneled in curled juniper that Asa Quidley had planed by hand until it shone like the inside of a shell. Ellis named it Redhead, for the duck, the one the Northern men paid the most to shoot after the canvasback. Over the front door, because his mother had wanted it there, Asa had cut a line of Scripture into a juniper board and gilded the letters: EXCEPT THE LORD BUILD THE HOUSE, THEY LABOUR IN VAIN THAT BUILD IT.

The Northern clubs were all up and down the sound by then, the Currituck Shooting Club, the Lighthouse Club, the Swan Island Club, a

dozen more, long low houses where bankers from New York and steel men from Pittsburgh came down by private car to Norfolk every November and shot ducks until March. Their guides were Banks men who paddled them out to the blinds before light and set out the decoys and picked up the birds. Ellis had been one of those guides. At twelve he had poled a skiff for a broker named Mr. Whitlock who tipped him a silver dollar a day, and at fifteen Mr. Whitlock had taken him north on the steamer to be an office boy in Wall Street, and by thirty-two he had a seat on the Exchange, a house on Washington Square, a wife from one of the old Knickerbocker families, and something over three million dollars, most of it made in a single week in May of 1901, when the Northern Pacific corner broke half the Street.

He had come home to build something the club men would row past and look at.

They did. That summer the whole sound rowed past and looked at it. The Northern men's wives came over from the Lighthouse Club in their launches with field glasses. And Ellis Tillett walked through his empty rooms in the evening with his hands in his pockets, and his heels rang on the juniper, and he thought: there is not another house like this one on God's earth.

Then he thought: there could be.

He sent for Asa.

Asa Quidley was forty-four, a long quiet man with sawdust in the creases of his neck, the best carpenter between Norfolk and Hatteras and the best maker of decoys. In the winter, when there was no building, he carved canvasbacks and redheads out of juniper and painted them so true that the live birds came down to them from a mile up. He had built Redhead from Ellis's drawings and his own head, and most of it was his own head.

Asa, have you ever built a house like this before?

No, sir. Not anything like it.

Could you build another?

Asa thought about it honestly, which was his way.

I expect I could build a better one, now I know how.

II. Seasoned Juniper

Redhead · September to November 1902

Edith Tillett's brother Teddy came down for September. He was twenty-two and had just finished at Yale and did not know what to do with himself, and he was the only one of Edith's people who liked Ellis, and the only one Ellis liked. He spent his days in the skiff with Asa, fishing and learning the sound, and his evenings on the porch with Ellis and the brandy.

One night late, with Edith gone up to bed, Ellis told him what was in his mind.

He said it quietly and reasonably, the way he talked about money. Asa could build another house. Some Pittsburgh man would see Redhead and want one, and Asa would build it, better. Then there would be two, and nothing special about either. Ellis did not intend to let that happen. A carpenter needed his hands and his eyes. There were men in Norfolk who would see to it for a hundred dollars, a fall in the boathouse, a splash of lime. Or there was the sound. Men drowned in the sound every winter and nobody asked.

Teddy laughed, waiting for the joke to finish. It did not finish. Ellis poured more brandy and talked about the price of juniper.

Teddy did not sleep. In the morning before light he walked down the boardwalk to the boathouse, where Asa was already at his bench, and stood in the door.

Asa, is the house finished?

All but the trim in the cupola.

Then listen to me. He told him. He was shaking. *He means it. I don't know what he means exactly but he means it.*

Asa set down his plane. He looked at the boy a while.

That's a kindness, Mr. Teddy, he said. *I won't forget it. Now I know what to do.*

When Ellis came down to the boathouse that afternoon to ask after the cupola, Asa said it was not near finished. There was a good deal still to do.

What?

I'll show you when it's done. I need wood.

What wood?

Juniper. Seasoned. Three years dry at the least. There's a mill up at the Dismal Swamp that has it. Green wood won't do for what I've got in mind.

Order it.

And I'd as soon nobody came in the loft while I work, Asa said. *It's fine work. I can't have people talking at me. Mattie can bring my dinner.*

Ellis ordered the wood. It came down from the Swamp on a schooner, a whole deckload of white cedar, dry as a bone and light as cork, and Asa carried it up into the boathouse loft and shut the door. Ellis was pleased. He had a feeling the cupola would be something. To be sure of the rest of it, he brought two men down from Norfolk and gave them a room over the boathouse and told them nobody went in or out but Asa and his wife, and Asa did not leave the property.

All October, Mattie Quidley came along the boardwalk at noon with a covered dish. The guards lifted the cloth and looked at the fish and the cornbread and let her by. She went home through the village every evening and sold something each time: the cow, the second skiff, the pump organ, the house itself at last to her sister's husband. She took the money in gold, ten-dollar eagles, and sewed them into the hem of her good skirt.

That was the autumn the two brothers from Dayton were down at Kill Devil Hills again with their glider. Everybody on the Banks had seen it by then, the big white double wing riding the wind off the dunes with a man lying flat in the middle of it, setting down light as a gull on the sand a long way off. The Bankers had views about it. Most of them held that if the Lord had meant men to fly He would have given them feathers. Before the cold came the brothers went home to Ohio and left the glider shut up in their shed on the sand, and the Banks went back to fishing.

On the twelfth of November, a still grey morning, Mattie came along the boardwalk at seven with the children, Ben who was ten and Zilphy who was seven, in their Sunday clothes, and told the guards that Asa had sent for them to see the work before it was done. The guards let them up. They were not told to keep out children.

A quarter of an hour later the big loft door at the sound end of the boathouse swung open from inside, and the bird came out.

The guards saw it from below. Ellis saw it from the porch with his coffee. Half the village saw it from the shore. It was a swan, a whistling swan such as came down onto Currituck by the thousands every winter, carved out of the white juniper and longer than a skiff, every feather cut, its long neck out straight and its black bill pointed west. It dropped off the sill of the loft and fell a little toward the water, and then it caught the air, the way the Ohio men's glider caught it off the dunes, and its wings went down once with a sound like a sail filling, and it rose. Mattie's face was at a window in its side. Zilphy's hand was waving.

One of the guards shouted, *Mr. Tillett, he's gone, the carpenter's gone!* and fired his pistol into the air, which did nothing at all. The swan went off over the sound toward the mainland, low and steady, getting small, and then it was a white speck over the trees beyond Coinjock, and then it was not anything.

They never found Asa Quidley. A peddler who came through the next summer said there was a man in the mountains past Asheville, on a high bald a long way from any road, who had built himself a whole little town of white wood with his own hands, church and mill and all, and the mountain people called him the Wooden King, and whether that was Asa nobody could say. There was a good deal of juniper shavings in the loft. Ellis had them swept up and burned.

III. The Carpets

Redhead · December 18, 1902

The cupola was never finished, but Ellis gave his party anyway.

He brought the Northern men over from the clubs in his launch, with their wives. Edith's people came down from New York in a private car. He asked the Methodist preacher from Kitty Hawk, and hired a cook from Norfolk and an orchestra of four. There was canvasback roasted twelve minutes, and diamondback terrapin, and Lynnhaven oysters by the

barrel, and champagne. But the guest Ellis wanted was Mrs. Tamsey Twiford, keeper of the Narrows light.

The Narrows light stood on iron legs in four feet of water a mile out in the sound, a square white cottage with a lantern on its roof, and Tamsey Twiford had kept it eleven years, since her husband Joel went through the ice coming back from Coinjock with the mail. She was fifty. The Lighthouse Board had made her keeper because there was nobody who knew the light better and because the inspector, after watching her clean the lens in her linen apron, had not been able to think of a reason not to. She had two assistants, her nephew Lige Gallop, who was nineteen, and old Mr. Baum, who was deaf, and the three of them divided every night into three watches, sunset to ten, ten to two, two to sunrise, and took them in turn, and one of them was always awake in the lantern room with the light.

Ellis Tillett had been hers since before he was born. That was how he put it. His mother had been caught out on the sound in an open boat in the gale of '69, eight months gone with him, and had made the Narrows light in the dark, and Tamsey, who was then a girl of seventeen and the keeper's daughter, had pulled her up the ladder and sat with her all night. At eight years old he had fallen through the ice off the Narrows and Tamsey had come out on her belly with a boathook. At fourteen, when Mr. Whitlock offered to take him north, it was Tamsey he went out to the light to ask, and Tamsey who said, *Go.* He said she was the only person on the Banks he had never once lied to.

He had a notion about her, and he had told it to nobody but Edith.

They had been married six years and there was no child. There had been two that did not come to term. Edith had been to doctors in New York and Philadelphia and a spa in Germany, and Ellis had paid for all of it and none of it had done any good. He was a Banks boy under the Wall Street clothes, and the Banks were full of signs, and the Bible he had been raised on was full of them too. Gideon had put out a fleece, and the Lord had wet it or kept it dry, as Gideon asked.

So Ellis laid out a fleece.

He had Turkey carpets, red and blue, the best in the house, laid end to end from the bottom of the landing stairs at the dock, all the way up the boardwalk and the steps and in through the front door under the gilded Psalm, to the head of the dining room table. He said to Edith, *If she walks in on them, we'll have a child. If she won't, we won't.*

Edith said he was being a Banker.

I am a Banker, said Ellis.

The light's skiff came in to the dock at noon, Lige rowing and Tamsey in the stern in her black dress and her black straw hat, and Ellis went down the carpets himself to meet her and took her hand and helped her up onto the landing.

Come in, Aunt Tamsey.

She looked at the carpets going away up the boardwalk, red and blue in the white December sun, and she did not move.

Come in. They're all waiting.

She did not move.

Aunt Tamsey. Please. Come on in the house.

She stood on the bare boards of the landing at the end of the first carpet, with her hands folded in front of her, and she looked at Lige.

Lige was tying up the skiff. He had known her all his life and stood watches with her for three years, and he knew what the look meant the way he knew what the light meant when the flame went yellow. He finished his knot and came up onto the landing.

Ellis, he said, *you'd best have them roll those up. She won't walk on them.* He said it kindly. *She's thinking about what comes after.*

So the Norfolk men who had been the guards rolled up the carpets, all the way to the dining room, while the guests watched from the porch, and Tamsey Twiford walked up the bare boardwalk on the grey juniper planks with her nephew behind her and went in under the gilded Psalm.

IV. Gull Shoal

The dining room

SHE ATE WHAT WAS GIVEN HER, A LITTLE OF THE CANVASBACK and a piece of bread, and drank water. When the orchestra stopped for its supper and the guests went out on the porch to look at the sound, Ellis sat down by her at the end of the table.

Aunt Tamsey. I've been yours three times over. Since before I was born. You know it. Why wouldn't you walk on my carpets?

What did you put them down for, Ellis?

He told her. Gideon and the fleece.

That's why, she said.

He looked at her. She had small hard brown hands and grey eyes, and she was the only person on the Banks he had never lied to.

Then there won't be any.

No.

Not ever.

No.

Why? What did I do?

She did not answer that at once. She looked out the window at the sound, at the low grey line of the marsh islands to the south, and she said, as if it were a different subject:

You know Gull Shoal.

He knew it. A low island of sand and grass in the sound, a couple of miles below the Narrows, where the terns and the black skimmers nested in May so thick you could not walk without stepping on eggs. He had gone egging there with his father every spring when he was a boy, with a basket on each arm. Later the plume buyers had come down from New York, and he and his father had gone over with guns.

There was a man and a woman came ashore there off a wreck, Tamsey said. *Before my time. Before my mother's time. A schooner broke up off the beach in a norther and everybody on her drowned but those two, and they came through the inlet on a hatch cover and fetched up on Gull Shoal. And there wasn't anything there to eat but birds' eggs. So they ate the eggs. They made a fire of wreck*

wood and cooked them in the coals, and that was all right, you've got to live. But the eggs gave out. So then they ate the young ones. The little speckled ones that can't fly yet, that you can pick up in your hand. And then the old birds. And then the eggs again next spring, and the young ones.

Somebody would have come for them.

Somebody came. Boats came by. They hid. They liked it there. They had all they could eat and nobody to tell them anything. They stayed on Gull Shoal and ate the birds when they were young, and when they were grown, and when they were old and grey. And not once in all that time, Ellis, not once in their whole lives, did either one of them keep a watch. Not one night. Not one hour of one night. They never set a lantern. They never once looked up from the fire to see what was coming, or who was out there on the water, or what they were doing to the island. Neither one of them. Not once.

What happened to them?

They died there. No children. Nothing came after them. She turned back from the window and looked at him. *If they'd kept one watch. If either one of them had, the man or the woman, one, in all those years, young or grown or old, it'd have been a different story.*

Who were they?

You know who they were.

He sat there in the juniper room he had built and looked at his own hands on the white tablecloth. They were Banks hands still, broad, with old scars across the knuckles from shucking and from the oarlocks. He thought about the baskets of eggs. He thought about the skimmers lying in rows on the sand with their wings spread, and his father cutting out the plumes, and the plumes going north to be put on hats, and about the hats, and about Edith's hats. He thought about Asa Quidley's eyes, and the lime, and the price he had named for it, as if it had been the price of juniper.

We stand three watches out at the light, Tamsey said. *Lige and old Baum and me. A night's too long for one. But anybody can keep one.*

Then she took a little book out of her bag. It was an old hymnbook with the back broken, printed in New York before her mother was born, that had come down to her from her mother's mother, a Methodist from

the time when there was only one kind. She did not need to open it. She knew it. She said it to him the way she said everything, low and plain, as if she were reading off the time of high water.

> *We will not close our wakeful eyes,*
> *We will not let our eyelids sleep;*
> *But humbly lift them to the skies,*
> *And all a solemn vigil keep;*
> *So many nights on sin bestow'd,*
> *Can we not watch one hour for God?*
>
> *— Hymn 164, "Watch Night," A Collection of Hymns for the Use of the Methodist Episcopal Church (1838)*

Out on the porch the Northern men were laughing at something. The orchestra came back from its supper and began to tune.

Ellis Tillett sat for a while with his head down. When he lifted it, there was something in his face that Edith, coming in from the porch, did not recognize. She said afterward that it was the face of a boy she had never met, a boy of about eight who has just been pulled out through the ice, lying flat on the boards of a lighthouse landing, looking up.

V. One Watch

Gull Shoal · May 1903

The legislature at Raleigh passed a law that spring putting the gulls and terns and herons of North Carolina under the protection of the new Audubon Society, with wardens to enforce it, and the plume buyers stopped coming to the Banks, or came at night. Ellis Tillett bought Gull Shoal from the county outright, all forty acres of sand and grass, and paid a warden's wages out of his own pocket to Lige Gallop, who took them, and the Bankers said Ellis had got religion, or got old, or both.

He went over himself in May when the terns came in. He went the first night, and the second, and most of the nights of that nesting season, in a

skiff, alone, with a lantern and a blanket and a jug of water, and sat on a box at the high end of the island from ten o'clock until two. He did not sleep. He kept the lantern turned low and shaded on the water side, so the birds would not mind it and so that anybody coming in a boat from the south would see it a long way off and think better of what he was coming for.

Around him in the dark the island was alive. The terns sat their eggs in the open sand by the thousand, a pale shifting sheet of them going away into the night, and every so often one would stand and shake herself and settle again, and the whole colony would mutter and go quiet. Toward midnight the black skimmers went out over the sound in a long line, low, cutting the still water with their lower bills, and came back. The tide turned. A mile north, the Narrows light burned steady on its iron legs, and he knew which watch it was by the hour, and who was up there in the lantern room with the light, in her linen apron, awake.

At two o'clock he trimmed the wick and stood up stiffly from the box and rowed home across the sound in the dark. Behind him, on the sand where his feet had been, a tern walked over to the warm place and sat down in it.

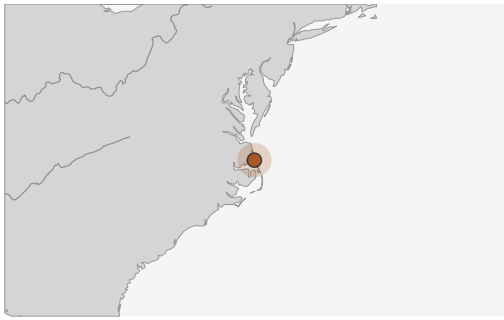
Background

The verse

> *If a man hold himself dear, let him watch himself carefully; during one at least out of the three watches a wise man should be watchful.*
>
> Dhammapada 157, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Prince Bodhi has a palace built so fine it seems to float in the air, and then, so that no one else will ever own one like it, plans to kill or blind the master builder. His friend Sañjikāputta warns the builder, who says the work is not done, asks for seasoned timber and privacy, and secretly carves a great wooden bird; his wife sells everything for gold, and one morning after breakfast the family flies out the window past the prince's guards, to found a city in the Himālaya where the builder is known as King Wooden Vehicle. The childless prince invites the Buddha to the palace festival and lays cloths from the threshold, thinking that if the Buddha

steps on them he will have a child. The Buddha refuses three times and looks at Ānanda, who has the cloths rolled up. Asked why, the Buddha tells of a husband and wife shipwrecked on an island who lived all their lives on the eggs and young of its birds and were never heedful in youth, middle age or old age; if either had kept watch in even one of those three periods, the prince would have had a child. Read the full commentary story, or the Buddha's visit to Prince Bodhi in the Bodhirājakumāra Sutta (Majjhima Nikāya 85).



Currituck Banks, North Carolina

The Currituck Banks, 1902

From the 1850s, when the Currituck Shooting Club was formed, wealthy Northern sportsmen built clubs and lodges along Currituck Sound and hired local Bankers as guides, while market hunters shipped barrels of canvasback, redhead and other ducks north by the week. In Kitty Hawk at the 1900 census most men fished, fifteen were surfmen in the Life-Saving Service, and a few listed themselves as hunters of wild fowl. The Wright brothers flew their 1902 glider again and again from the Kill Devil Hills that autumn and left it in their camp over the winter; they returned to fly the powered Flyer in December 1903. Ellis Tillett's fortune comes from the Northern Pacific corner and the Panic of 1901.

The Narrows light and Gull Shoal are invented, but the Lighthouse Board did appoint women keepers on the North Carolina coast and sounds, most of them wives or daughters of keepers, who stood their share of the night watches, kept the log and wore linen aprons to clean the lens (Coastal Review). By the turn of the century the plume trade had stripped the state's gull, tern and heron colonies; in March 1903 the legislature passed the Audubon Act, drafted by T. Gilbert Pearson, which gave the new Audubon Society of North Carolina wardens and the power to enforce bird and game laws. Mrs. Twiford's hymnbook is A Collection of Hymns for the Use of the Methodist Episcopal Church (New York, 1838), printed before the church divided North and South in 1844; hymn 164 is "Watch Night."

After the story of Prince Bodhi from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 157). The original. Scripture from the King James Version and a Methodist Episcopal hymnal of 1838. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

12.2

The Middle Portion

But having food and covering we shall be therewith content.
— 1 Timothy 6:8

Ετσι τ' ακουσα, in the cook car below the bluffs at Fallbridge.

I. Food and Covering

Bingham Canyon, Utah · Cheesefare Sunday, 1914

Father Chrysanthos Doukas had a voice they talked about in three states. He had been trained at the Rizarios school in Athens and had served in Chicago and in Lowell, and in each place he had left the community board weeping at his sermons and furious over his accounts, and he had come west that winter with two trunks, a letter from a bishop nobody in Utah had heard of, and no community of his own. The men said he could read the Gospel so that you saw the boat rocking. The men also said, more quietly, that his hands were quick.

On the Sunday before the Great Fast he preached to the Cretans of the Bingham copper camp in the hall over a coffeehouse, at the memorial for two men killed in a cave-in at the Highland Boy. These Cretans were the hard ones of the canyon. They kept the Fast the old way, without oil from Monday to Friday, and they slept six to a shack and sent everything home. Father Chrysanthos took for his text the sixth chapter of Paul to Timothy, and he leaned on it the way a man leans on a gate.

> *But godliness with contentment is great gain: for we brought nothing into the world, for neither can we carry anything out; but having food and covering we shall be therewith content.*
>
> *— 1 Timothy 6:6–8*

He said that the two dead men had gone down the mountain with nothing in their hands, and that every man in the hall would do the same, and he named the things they would leave behind, the shirts and the watches and the money orders, until the hall was quiet enough to hear the stove tick. Food and covering, he said. A loaf, and a coat on your back, and God. What more did your grandfathers have in the mountains of Sfakia? What more did the Apostle have?

The Cretans wept. Then they did what men do who have been moved and have nothing else to give. They took up a collection that came to a hundred and eleven dollars. One gave him a sheepskin coat with the fleece turned in, new from the company store. One gave him two shirts of good wool. Their headman took down from the shelf at the end of the hall the brass censer and the little silver lamp they had bought by subscription two years before, against the day a priest would come up the canyon to serve them, and asked him to bless the things and use them while he was there.

He blessed them and used them. When he left on the morning train he had the coat on his back and the shirts in his trunk, and the censer and the lamp were in the trunk with the shirts. The Cretans noticed the empty shelf on Tuesday. Nobody said anything for a week, because he was a priest. Then somebody did.

II. Four Towns

The Oregon Short Line · the first week of Lent

In those years there was no bishop over the Greeks in America who could make a priest go anywhere. Every community was its own master. The men of a town got together, elected a board, rented a hall or built a church, and sent for a priest, or hired one who was passing, and paid him what they had agreed, and fired him when they felt like it. And a priest who was passing could ask what a town was offering before he unpacked.

The Greeks of Pocatello met him at the depot with a delegation of four in their Sunday hats. They were shop men and section men of the Short

Line, and they had no church and no priest, and they wanted a preacher for the Fast and someone to give them the Resurrection at midnight in the Odd Fellows' hall. They had heard about the voice. They took him to the coffeehouse and gave him the chair by the stove.

And what does the community give, said Father Chrysanthos, *to a priest who keeps the Fast here and stays for Pascha?*

Sixty dollars, Father, and your board.

He said he would think about it and asked the way to the hotel, and in the morning he took the westbound train, and left a pair of galoshes behind in the corner of the coffeehouse by the stove.

At La Grande, where the Greeks worked in the Union Pacific shops and kept a room over a fruit store for a chapel, he asked the same question.

Eighty dollars, Father, and the room.

He left his ebony walking stick in the umbrella stand of the fruit store and took the next train west.

At The Dalles they were fewer and poorer, mostly men off the river line, and they offered a hundred because they had been saving since Christmas. He drank their coffee, said it was the best he had tasted since Smyrna, and left behind on the counter of the restaurant on Second Street his brass briki, the long-handled coffee pot he had carried with him from Athens, which his mother had used before him.

In Portland they offered a hundred and fifty dollars for the Fast and Pascha, and the rooms over a confectioner's on Front Street, and a fee for each sermon besides.

Very good, said Father Chrysanthos. *I will stay here.*

It rained in Portland from the first day of the Fast to the last. He preached on Wednesdays and Fridays to the shoeshine men and the peddlers and the candy-makers and the mill hands, and on Sundays to everybody, and men came down from the camps on the river on the Saturday night trains to hear him. He preached on the rich man and Lazarus. He preached on the lilies of the field that toil not, neither do they spin. He preached on food and covering. The bootblacks who stood in the back in their aprons said they had never heard anything like it, and the confec-

tioners brought him boxes of loukoumi, and the ladies of the community, who were only a few, sent him a bolt of gold brocade for a new vestment and lengths of black wool for a new cassock, and men pressed coins into his hand at the door.

III. The Cook Car

Fallbridge, Washington · Lent 1914

A HUNDRED MILES UP THE RIVER THE EXTRA GANG OF THE Spokane, Portland and Seattle was relaying steel east of Fallbridge, where the new bridge of the Oregon Trunk crossed over to the Deschutes. There were forty-one men in the gang, nearly all of them from the villages around Tripoli in Arcadia, and they lived in six bunk cars on a siding below the bluffs, with a cook car at the end and a water car behind it. They worked ten hours a day, and on Sundays too when the roadmaster said so, and in the evenings the wind came up the Gorge from the west and drove grit into everything, into the bread and the blankets and the creases of their eyelids. On still nights they could hear Celilo, the falls where the river people fished, five miles off, a sound like a crowd that never went home.

The cook was a monk.

His name was Gerasimos and he was past sixty. He had come out from a small house of monks on the Holy Mountain two years before with a letter from his elder, to go among the Greeks of America and beg for a new roof, because the old one let the snow onto the altar. He had gone to Chicago, and to Salt Lake, and up the canyons and along the lines, and he had seen how the men lived, six to a car, sleeping on gunny sacks, eating what the boarding contractors gave them, sending every dollar home for their sisters' dowries and their fathers' debts, and he had not had the heart to ask them for anything. So he had written to his elder that he would earn the roof instead, and he had hired on as cook to the first Greek gang that would have him. He sent eight dollars a month to the Holy Mountain and kept nothing. He slept on a shelf in the cook car above the flour barrels, under one army blanket.

He did not preach. In Lent he cooked beans, and lentils, and chick-peas, and bread that he baked in an oven he had dug into the clay bank of the cut and lined with stones, the way they did at home. On Saturdays and Sundays there was oil on the beans and sometimes octopus from a tin. In the evenings, when the plates were washed, he stood between the stove and the flour barrels with his face to a paper icon of the Mother of God pinned to the wall, and said the prayer of Saint Ephraim, and went down three times on his knees with his forehead to the boards, and got up again with one hand on a barrel. He did it every evening of the Fast. The first week, two or three men stayed in the car and did it with him. By the third week there was not room for everybody, and men knelt on the ground outside the open door, in the wind.

> *O Lord and Master of my life, grant not unto me a spirit of slothfulness, of discouragement, of lust of power, of vain babbling.*
>
> *But vouchsafe unto thy servant the spirit of continence, of meekness, of patience, and of love.*
>
> *— Prayer of St. Ephraim the Syrian*

Three cousins from the village of Piana had the bunks at the end of the third car. Stavros was the eldest, twenty-four, slow and careful, with four sisters at home and a ledger in his pocket in which he kept, to the penny, what each of their dowries still lacked. Mitsos was nineteen and had a voice like a goat and a temper that came and went like the wind in the cut. Yannis was between them in age and in everything else. He was the one who made peace.

Yannis had two suits, a black one for church and a grey one he had bought in Portland for a photograph to send home, and he had a robe. He had bought it the autumn before from a trader at The Dalles who sold to the river people, a Pendleton robe from the mills at Pendleton, heavy as a sheep, banded in red and black and yellow, and it had cost him more than two weeks' pay. Stavros had told him he was a fool. Mitsos had told him it was the most beautiful thing in Washington. Yannis said it was the first

thing he had ever owned that was not for somebody else, and he slept under it, and the other two slept closer to his bunk than they needed to.

On the Sunday of the Cross, the third Sunday of the Fast, the gang was working in the cut west of the bridge, and the wind had been at the bluff all night, and a slab of basalt the size of a wagon let go above them without a sound until it hit. The others ran. Yannis was tamping under a tie with his back to the hill.

There was no priest nearer than Portland, and the railroad would not hold a body. They buried him the next morning on the flat above the siding, in his black suit, with a cross the monk made out of two pieces of a broken tie. Gerasimos read the Trisagion over him, the prayers for the dead that a monk who is not a priest is allowed to read, and the gang sang the responses into the wind. Afterward the monk boiled wheat in the cook car and mixed it with sugar and a little cinnamon from a tin, and they ate it standing by the grave, a spoonful each, for the soul.

That night Stavros wrote to the famous preacher in Portland. The forty days would fall in May. Would the Father do them the honor, on his way wherever he went after Pascha, of stopping at Fallbridge to sing the memorial over their cousin's grave? The gang would make a collection.

The Father wrote back on the stationery of the confectioner on Front Street. He would be travelling east by the river line after Pascha. He would stop.

IV. Bright Week

Portland · Pascha, April 1914

On Holy Friday the women covered the bier of Christ with flowers from the market, and the men carried it around the block in the rain behind the candles, and the Father sang the Lamentations so that the confectioners wept into their beards. On Saturday at midnight he came out of the dark sanctuary with one candle and sang *Come, receive the light,* and the light went from his candle to the first hand and the next and through the whole church and out the doors into the street, where there was not room for everybody, and the bells rang, and the men

SHOUTED *CHRIST IS RISEN* AT EACH OTHER AND CRACKED RED eggs, and the shoeshine boys who had come in from the camps let off pistols at the sky. It was the best Pascha anybody in Portland could remember. They said so for years.

In Bright Week, while the town was still eating lamb, Father Chrysanthos sat in his rooms over the confectioner's and wrote three letters, each in his beautiful seminary hand.

To Pocatello he wrote that he had left his galoshes with them as a pledge that he was among them in spirit through the holy Fast, and that he prayed for them by name every day of it, and that the community would surely wish to send what was customary for a priest who has kept the Fast for a community, together with the galoshes. To La Grande he wrote the same, about the stick. To The Dalles he wrote the same, about the briki, his mother's briki, which he could not live without.

Pocatello sent the galoshes and thirty dollars. La Grande sent the stick and forty. The Dalles sent the briki wrapped in a newspaper and the whole hundred they had saved since Christmas, with a note from their president that said they were sorry it could not be more.

He had a third trunk made for the brocade and the black wool. He bought a gold watch on Washington Street. When he went down to the Union Station in the first week of May there were five pieces of baggage on the cart, and the porter had to make two trips.

V. The Division

Fallbridge · May 1914

HE GOT OFF THE TRAIN IN A BLACK CASSOCK WITH THE SHEEPskin coat over his arm against the wind and the silver watch-chain of the Cretans across his front, and the whole gang was at the siding to meet him in their good clothes. The roadmaster had given them the afternoon. The monk had made koliva in the big pot, wheat and walnuts and raisins and sugar, and smoothed the top of it with the flat of a knife and laid a cross on it in almonds, and the men carried it up the path to the flat above the siding on a board.

Father Chrysanthos sang the memorial at the grave in that voice, and the wind took it out over the river, and some of the men said afterward that the river people fishing at the falls must have heard it. He sang *Memory eternal* three times, and the gang sang it after him, and Stavros and Mitsos stood at the foot of the tie-cross with their hats in their hands and did not look at each other. The collection came to thirty-eight dollars. He blessed the koliva and took a spoonful and took the collection.

Then he came down to the third car to see the young man's things, because Stavros asked him to.

Yannis's things were on his bunk. There was a razor and a strop, a bundle of letters from his mother, a photograph of himself in the grey suit, and the grey suit, and the robe, folded so the red band showed. The black suit was in the ground.

The cousins had been quarrelling over the robe for forty days. Stavros said the suit and the letters and the razor would go home to the mother, and the robe should be sold in The Dalles for what it would bring, and the money put to the dowries of Yannis's own sisters, because that was what was right. Mitsos said Yannis had slept under that robe, and it was not a thing to be sold to some stranger, and he would keep it and sleep under it himself and remember him, and Stavros was a bookkeeper with no heart. Stavros said Mitsos only wanted it because it was beautiful. Mitsos said Stavros only wanted the money for the ledger. They had said worse things than that in the forty days. Twice the foreman had pulled them apart.

They stood in the narrow aisle of the bunk car on either side of the priest, with the other men crowding the doorway behind, and Stavros said, *Father, you are an educated man and a priest of God. You divide it for us, however you think right, and that will be the end of it.*

Will you both abide by what I decide?

We will, said Stavros. Mitsos said it too, after a moment.

Very good, said Father Chrysanthos.

He gave the razor and the strop and the photograph to Stavros, to send home to the mother with the letters. He gave the grey suit to Mitsos,

since he was nearly the dead man's size, so that he would have something of his cousin's to wear to church. Then he picked up the robe and shook it out, and it fell open from his hands to the floor of the car, red and black and gold, and the men in the doorway made a sound.

As for this, he said, *it is not a thing to be fought over by young men, or sold in a shop. It is a priest's cloth. This belongs on the shoulders of those who preach the word of God.*

He folded it once over his arm, and thanked them for their hospitality, and said he would wait for the eastbound at the depot, and went out through the men in the doorway, who stood aside for him because he was a priest.

VI. The Fox

The cook car · that evening

THE COUSINS CAME TO THE COOK CAR AT DUSK. THE MONK was scouring the koliva pot with sand. They told him all of it, both talking at once, and when they had told it they were not angry at each other anymore, only at the priest, and ashamed, and sick, the way you feel after you have been robbed in front of people.

Gerasimos set the pot down.

It is not the first time, he said. *That one has been taking from your plates since before you were born.*

Then he sat down on a flour barrel and told them a story, the way he told the boys stories at night in the village on the Holy Mountain when they had been fighting, and the men in the car went quiet to listen.

Once, he said, below the falls, there were two otters. One of them hunted along the bank in the shallows and one of them hunted out in the deep water, and between them, working together, they caught a red salmon so big that the two of them together could hardly drag it out onto the rock. And then they could not agree how to share it. *The head is mine,* said the one. *The tail is yours. No, the head is mine,* said the other. And while they were shouting, a fox came down the bank, a fine one, with a fine tail.

Uncle, they said, *you divide it for us.*

I can't, said the fox. *The eagle has made me a judge, and I sit in court all day long. I only came down here to stretch my legs.*

Uncle, don't say that. Divide it for us, and that will be the end of it.

Will you both abide by what I decide?

We will.

Very good, said the fox. And he bit off the head and laid it to one side, and bit off the tail and laid it to the other side, and said, *The one who runs along the bank shall have the tail, and the one who swims in the deep water shall have the head. And this middle portion belongs to the court.* And he took the whole middle of the salmon in his mouth and went up the bank with it, and the two otters sat on the rock, one with a head and one with a tail, and watched his fine tail go away into the sagebrush.

Mitsos laughed in spite of himself, and then put his face in his hands. Stavros did not laugh.

That fox has eaten from a great many plates, said the monk. *In my village and in yours. In Smyrna and in Chicago. He ate your fathers' fish, too.* He put his hand on the back of Mitsos's neck, the way you would with a mule. *It is gone. Let it go, both of you. You still have each other, and that cost you nothing, and nobody can carry it off over his arm.*

• • •

The eastbound was late. It was late most nights, and that night it would not reach Fallbridge until after one. The foreman, who was a Greek himself and could not have the priest sitting alone in the depot all evening, brought him down to the cook car for supper, and he came with the robe over his shoulders against the wind, the way you would wear a shawl.

It was still the season of the Resurrection, and there was meat. The monk had made a stew of mutton and potatoes for the gang. The men ate in silence at the long plank tables, and the priest sat at the end by the stove, and talked a little about Portland and about the war in the Balkans that was over now, and nobody answered him.

The monk brought him his plate himself. He set it down, and the bread beside it, and stood a moment with the empty pan in his hands. He

did not raise his voice. He said it the way he said everything, the way he might have told a man there was more stew if he wanted it, so that only the near tables heard, and the near tables told the rest.

> *Thou therefore that teachest another, teachest thou not thyself? thou that preachest a man should not steal, dost thou steal?*
>
> *— Romans 2:21*

Father Chrysanthos looked up at him. He was a man who had an answer for everything, and he had stood up in front of community boards in Chicago and Lowell and talked them out of their own minutes. He opened his mouth to say something. Then he looked at the old man's hands on the pan, and at the patched cassock, and at the shelf over the flour barrels with the one army blanket folded on it, and he closed his mouth and looked at his plate.

He ate the stew. He thanked the cook. When the eastbound whistled for Fallbridge at a quarter past one he went up the path to the depot in the dark with the robe on his shoulders, and the gang heard the train take water and pull out, and that was all anybody on the north bank saw of him.

VII. The Prayer

Fallbridge · the next morning

THE COUSINS DID NOT SLEEP MUCH. TOWARD MORNING MITSOS said into the dark that he would like to break that priest's neck, and Stavros said he would hold his coat, and they lay there a while and found they did not mean it, and did not know what to do with what they did mean.

Before the gang went out they came to the cook car. The monk was at the oven in the bank with the long paddle, taking out the bread. They asked him what they should do about it. They meant about the priest. Should they write to the communities, to Portland, to The Dalles, to the newspaper in New York? Should they write to Yannis's mother and tell her where her son's robe had gone?

Gerasimos set the loaves on the board to cool. Then he told them the end of the prayer they had been saying with him on their knees every evening for seven weeks, the part they had said so many times that they had stopped hearing it.

> *Yea, O Lord and King, grant that I may perceive my own transgressions, and judge not my brother. For blessed art thou unto ages of ages. Amen.*
>
> *— Prayer of St. Ephraim the Syrian*

Start there, he said. *Then, if you still have something to teach him, you can go and teach it.*

They stood in the door of the cook car a long time. Mitsos said, finally, that he had called Stavros a bookkeeper with no heart, and that it was not true. Stavros said that he had wanted the money for the ledger, and that it was true. Then they had to go, because the foreman was shouting.

That night Mitsos packed the grey suit in brown paper with the razor and the strop and the photograph and the bundle of letters, and Stavros wrote to the mother in Piana, and they took it together to the depot to send. Stavros put in a money order for a little more than the robe would have brought in The Dalles. It was in both their names, and Stavros wrote it into the ledger in a column by itself.

They never wrote to Portland. In the autumn they heard from a man who had come up from Salt Lake that the Cretans of Bingham had got their censer back, by express, with no letter. Nobody knew what it meant, and the cousins did not ask.

• • •

On the first Sunday after the memorial there was no work, and the two of them walked down the bluff to the river below the cut, where the water came round the rocks green and fast from the falls. They sat on the basalt in the sun with one lunch pail between them and the bread from the monk's oven. Out on a flat rock in the current two otters had a salmon between them, a red one, and they were eating it from the two ends at

once, the one from the head and the one from the tail, working toward the middle.

Background

The verse

> *Let each man direct himself first to what is proper, then let him teach others; thus a wise man will not suffer.*
>
> Dhammapada 158, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Upananda is a gifted preacher and a greedy monk. After preaching on being content with little, he accepts a heap of robes from monks who keep the strict practices and carries off their utensils too. With the rains retreat coming, he asks four monasteries in turn what allowance they give a monk who spends the rains there, leaves his sandals at the first, his staff at the second and his water pot at the third, and settles at the fourth, which offers four robes. When the rains are over he sends for his belongings and claims the allowance from all four. On the road with his cartload he meets two young monks who cannot agree how to share two robes and a costly blanket. They ask him to divide them; he gives each a robe and walks off with the blanket, saying it belongs to those who preach. The Buddha tells the young monks the tale of two otters and a jackal who settles their quarrel over a fish by taking the middle for himself, and rebukes Upananda: one who admonishes others should first set himself right. Read the full commentary story; its fable is the Jātaka of the jackal Dabbhapuppha (no. 400).

Fallbridge, Washington

Greeks on the Columbia, 1914

Greek immigration to the United States peaked in the years before the First World War, driven by poor land, debt and the burden of providing dowries for sisters. In the

West most of the newcomers went first to the mines, the mills and the railroads: the 1910 census counted 3,448 Greeks in Oregon, more than 2,100 of them railroad workers, many on the Spokane, Portland and Seattle, built along the north bank of the Columbia. Extra gangs lived in bunk cars on sidings, worked ten-hour days and often fed themselves. Fallbridge (renamed Wishram in 1926) was the junction where the Oregon Trunk crossed the river, beside Celilo Falls, a fishing place of the river peoples for thousands of years until The Dalles Dam drowned it in 1957. In Utah some 1,200 Greeks were working the Utah Copper mine at Bingham by 1912. The heavy banded robes of Pendleton Woolen Mills, incorporated in 1909, were made first of all for Native buyers in the Northwest and were costly and prized.

Before 1921 there was no Greek bishop in America. The Church of Greece was given nominal authority over the immigrant parishes in 1908, but in practice each community was governed by its own elected board, which raised the money, built or rented a church and hired a priest, sometimes one who was passing through, and dismissed him when it chose. Portland's Holy Trinity, the first Greek Orthodox church in the Pacific Northwest, was founded in 1907; its stone church at Seventeenth and Taggart was finished in 1910. The Archdiocese was incorporated in 1921. The Prayer of St. Ephrem, said with prostrations on the weekdays of Great Lent, is quoted here in the translation of Isabel Hapgood's 1906 *Service Book*. Father Chrysanthos, the monk Gerasimos, the gang at Fallbridge and every community's offer are invented.

After the story of Upananda the Sakyan from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 158). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version and the Prayer of St. Ephraim the Syrian in Isabel F. Hapgood's *Service Book of the Holy Orthodox-Catholic Apostolic Church* (1906). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

12.3

The Gravedigger's Rooster

Blessed art thou, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who hast given to the cock intelligence to distinguish between day and night.
— The Authorised Daily Prayer Book, tr. S. Singer

Azoy hob ikh es gehert, by the coffee urn in Overland Park.

I. The First Shift

Overland Park, Kansas · Tuesday night, May 25, 1993

Shavuot came in on a Tuesday that year, and at Congregation Tifereth Jacob the evening service could not start until it was full dark, because the forty-nine days had to be finished first. So it was half past ten before Mel Tischler stood up in the social hall with a legal pad.

Mel was forty-six, a district sales manager for a business-forms company, and chairman of adult education. He coached his daughter's softball team, and most of the congregation called him Coach, including the rabbi. The all-night study was his idea. Tifereth Jacob had not held one since it moved out from the city in 1964, and Mel had read about them in a magazine.

Twenty-two people had stayed. They sat at round tables with paper cloths on them, under the fluorescent lights. There was a forty-cup urn of regular and a smaller one of decaf, two cheesecakes, and Mrs. Rosenbloom's blintz casserole under foil. Naomi Sacks was there because her son Josh was being confirmed in the morning and the confirmation class had been told to come. She was a night nurse at a hospital on the Missouri side, and this was her night off.

People, Mel said. *Here's the story. The morning God gave the Torah, our ancestors overslept. That's in the midrash. He's on the mountain, thunder, lightning, the whole production, and Moses has to go through the camp getting them up. So tonight we fix it. That's what tikkun means. It's a repair. We stay awake for them. Nobody sleeps on my watch.*

He had asked Mr. Plotkin what a person studied on such a night. Mr. Plotkin was the shammes, the sexton. He was eighty-one, he had the keys, and he knew where everything in the building was. He had gone to a cabinet and come back with a carton of little books that had made every move with the congregation and had not been opened since the first one. They were in Hebrew, in small type: the opening verses and the closing verses of every portion of the Torah, then of each of the Prophets and the Writings, then of each tractate of the Mishnah.

You read the beginning and the end of everything, Mr. Plotkin had said. *Nobody finishes. You taste.*

Mel had run off the English on the office copier, eleven pages, stapled, and he had divided the night into three shifts. Torah from ten-thirty to twelve-thirty. Prophets and Writings until two-thirty. Mishnah until four-thirty, then the morning service at a quarter past five so they would be standing when the sun came up.

This comes to you straight from Sinai, people, he said, *by way of Mr. Plotkin's cabinet. So let's give it everything.*

Mr. Plotkin sat for a while at the table nearest the door with one of the little books and a glass of tea, reading in an undertone. A little after eleven Mel bent down to him. *Go home, Mr. Plotkin. You need your rest. We've got it covered.* The old man looked at him and closed the book on his finger. Then he got his hat. He lived in the apartments across the road so that he would never have to drive on a Sabbath or a holiday. He said he would be back before five to open up the chapel.

At twenty to twelve Mel put down his coffee.

I'm going to close my eyes ten minutes in the rabbi's study, he said, *so I'm fresh for the changeover.*

II. The Changeovers

The social hall · half past twelve to four

AT TWELVE-THIRTY A SMALL DOUBLE BEEP CAME THROUGH THE door of the rabbi's study, and a moment later Mel came out with his hair flat on one side.

By then the room had found its way into the night. Dr. Mandel, a retired dentist, had been reading the last verses of Deuteronomy aloud to his table, and nobody at it was thinking about the time. Others had drifted. Four were in the kitchen eating cheesecake standing up. Three of the confirmation class were lying on the carpet in the youth lounge.

People, Mel said. *Did we come here to lie down? Is this what we're doing? Up. Back to the tables. Second shift. Sinai, people.*

He walked them in ahead of him and stood until every chair was filled. He said a few more words about commitment. Then he said he wanted to check a source, and the study door closed behind him.

It took the room half an hour to get back to where it had been. Naomi was in the Book of Ruth. She knew that hour from the floor, the one where the body asks to be let off, and she knew the only cure for it was to have something in front of you that needed doing. She had just found it again when the beep came through the door at two-thirty.

This time he found people on the padded bench in the lobby, under the memorial plaques with their little bulbs, and Mrs. Rosenbloom in the kitchen wrapping the casserole. He brought them all back. He said this was the home stretch. He said the people who built this congregation had not built it on eight hours' sleep. He looked at his watch, thumbed it, and went to check another source.

After that nobody could keep to a page. They were too tired to read and too stirred up to rest, and every one of them was listening for the door. Six went home.

I'll say this for him, Dr. Mandel said. *The man is a dynamo. Where does he get it? He's in there with the commentaries while the rest of us fall on our faces. Naomi, go and look. You're the professional.*

She went, and Josh went with her. She opened the study door the way she opened a door on the ward at that hour.

Mel Tischler lay on the rabbi's couch under the rabbi's raincoat with his mouth open. His shoes stood paired on the carpet. He had taken off his watch and set it on the arm of the couch, three inches from his ear.

She left the door standing open so the others could come and see, and they came, one at a time, quietly, as people file past at a funeral home.

So, Dr. Mandel said. *Forty years I told people to floss.*

Josh picked up the watch. It was the same Casio he had. He held down a button until the little bell on the face went out, and he set the watch back on the arm of the couch where it had been. His mother saw him do it and said nothing.

At four the lawn sprinklers came on outside by themselves. There were nine people left in the social hall, and not one of them could have told you what the Mishnah was about.

III. The Gravedigger's Rooster

A quarter to five

Mr. Plotkin came across the dark lot in a suit and a hat with his tallis bag under his arm. He looked at the nine of them, and at the six chairs somebody had pushed together for Mrs. Rosenbloom, and at the cheesecake.

Nu, he said. *You learned?*

They told him all of it, the shifts and the speeches and the beep through the door. Dr. Mandel told most of it. Mr. Plotkin looked over once at the study, where a raincoat rose and fell. He sat down and put his hat on the table.

By us, in Lithuania, my father was the shammes, he said. *Every morning before light he went down the street with a wooden hammer and knocked on the shutters. Three knocks, so a person knew it was time to get up and come to shul. That was for the householders. The boys in the study house got up before that, in the middle of the night, to learn. For them my father didn't knock. They kept a rooster.*

The rooster died. So one of the boys got another one from the gravedigger, who kept a few chickens by the cemetery wall. This one was hatched out there by himself. No hen sat on him. He never once heard an old rooster. And by a cemetery it's quiet, one hour is the same as another hour. So he crowed when it came into his head. He crowed at midnight, and the boys got up and learned until they fell asleep on the page, and when it was really morning they were no good to anybody. Then he crowed at noon, when they were trying to go over it. A week they stood this. Friday he was soup.

My father said, don't be angry with the rooster. Who showed him?

He took a prayer book out of the tallis bag. It was an old black one with English down the left-hand pages. He had owned it since 1923, the year he landed in Kansas City and taught himself to read English out of it. He turned it around on the table so they could see the place.

The first thing a Jew thanks for in the morning, when he comes to the blessings. Before his eyes, before his clothes, before his own two feet. This.

> *Blessed art thou, O Lord our God, King of the universe, who hast given to the cock intelligence to distinguish between day and night.*
>
> *— The Authorised Daily Prayer Book, tr. S. Singer, Morning Service*

To a rooster it's given. A person has to get it for himself, and from himself. It's very hard. To wake up another person is nothing, a hammer can do it. The one that's hard to wake up is you. He closed the book. *The Gemara says it short. K'shot atzm'cha, v'achar kach k'shot acherim.*

> *Improve thyself and then improve others.*
>
> *— Talmud, Baba Bathra 60b, tr. A. Cohen*

Then he got up and went to the door of the rabbi's study. It was open. He knocked on the frame anyway with one knuckle, three times, and in Yiddish, not loudly, he said what his father used to say to the shutters, which was that it was time to get up and serve the Creator.

He did not wait to see what came of it. He went into the chapel and put on his tallis. A person who has been up all night hears some of the morning blessings from one who has slept, so those were his to say, and

he began, and the nine of them stood up behind him. When he reached the blessing for the rooster the windows on the east side had gone gray, and every one of them was awake. Naomi thought she had not been so awake at any hour of the night. Out in the lot the lamp on its pole, which also knew, went off.

Mel Tischler came in during the next page with his shoes in his hand. Nobody turned around. Mrs. Rosenbloom found the place for him and held the book out, and he took it.

• • •

The next year there was no legal pad. Mr. Plotkin sat down at half past ten at the table nearest the door with a little book and a glass of tea, and he began at the beginning in an undertone. That was the whole program. Anyone who looked up at any hour of that night saw him there, eighty-two years old, with his finger on the line.

Twenty-six people saw the sun come up. Mel Tischler was one of them. He had sat at the old man's elbow since half past ten and had not made one remark to the room. His watch was out in the glove compartment of his Buick. He had set it before he thought, and then left it there, and at half past twelve it went off in the dark with nobody to hear it.

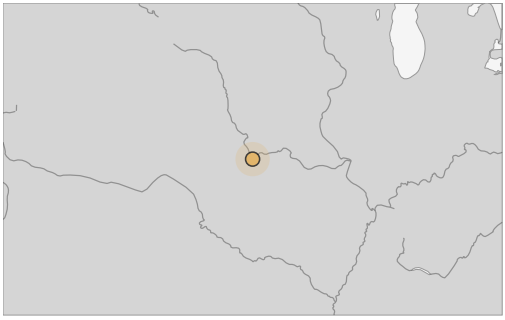
Background

The verse

> *If a man make himself as he teaches others to be, then, being himself well subdued, he may subdue (others); one's own self is indeed difficult to subdue.*
>
> Dhammapada 159, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the elder Padhānika Tissa, "Tissa the Striver," takes five hundred monks into the forest with a meditation subject they have had from the Buddha. He tells them to be heedful, lies down, and goes to sleep. When the monks come in to rest at the end of the first watch of the night he wakes, asks whether they came there to sleep, sends them out again, and goes back to bed; he does the same at the end of the middle watch. Worn out and unsettled, none of them gets anywhere. At last they decide that their teacher must be a man of tremendous energy, go to watch him, and

find out. When they return, the Buddha tells them it is not the first time. Once they were students who rose to their lessons at cockcrow. Their rooster died, and the one they got in his place had been raised in a cemetery and knew nothing of hours, so that he crowed at midnight and again at noon until they wrung his neck. No mother or father raised him, their teacher said, and he lived under no teacher. Read the full commentary story.



Overland Park, Kansas

Overland Park, 1993

Shavuot marks the giving of the Torah at Sinai, and in 1993 its first day fell on Wednesday, May 26. The custom of studying through the night before, the Tikkun Leil Shavuot, comes from the Zohar and the kabbalists who followed it. A later explanation, the one Mel gives, rests on a midrash to the Song of Songs in which Israel slept late on the morning of the revelation and had to be roused. The traditional book for the night is an anthology of beginnings and endings: the first and last verses of each portion of the Torah, of the other biblical books, and of the tractates of the Mishnah. The evening service of the festival waits for full dark so that the seven weeks counted from Passover are complete. After the Second World War many of Kansas City's Jewish families moved south and across the state line, and Overland Park, in Johnson County, Kansas, became the center of the community. Congregation Tifereth Jacob and its people are invented.

The blessing for the rooster stands first in the long row of morning blessings, and comes from the Talmud (Berakhot 60b), which appoints it for the moment a person hears the cock crow. The English is Simeon Singer's, from the Authorised Daily Prayer Book of 1890 (text), which was reprinted in America for decades. The saying from Baba Bathra is given as Abraham Cohen put it in Ancient Jewish Proverbs (1911). In the towns of Eastern Europe the sexton who went round before dawn knocking on doors and shutters to call people to prayer was the shulklapper, the synagogue knocker. Three knocks was one of the usual counts.

After the story of the elder Padhānika Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 159). The original. The blessing is from The Authorised Daily Prayer Book, tr. Simeon Singer (1890); the Talmud saying is from A. Cohen, Ancient Jewish Proverbs (1911). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

12.4

Mataji

The wise grieve neither for the living nor for the dead.
— Bhagavad Gita 2:11, tr. Annie Besant (1896)

I heard it like this, Prabhu, on the Salt River.

I. The Temple

Phoenix · 1973

Margaret Ashby wanted to be a nun from the time she was seven years old, and she was raised Presbyterian, which was the first problem. She asked her mother and father at seven and at twelve and at sixteen, in different words each time, and the answer was no each time, in the same words. Her father built shopping centers. He had built half of the ones on Camelback Road, and the house in Paradise Valley had a pool shaped like a kidney and a view of the mountain from every room, and his only daughter was not going to shut herself up in a convent with a lot of Catholics or anybody else.

So she married. She married Doug Pruitt, who was gentle and studying architecture at Arizona State and loved her more than she knew what to do with, and she was a good wife to him for two years in a little house in Tempe with a lemon tree in the yard. Then one evening on Mill Avenue she heard the chanting.

There were six of them on the sidewalk outside the bookstore, in saris and saffron cloth, with drums and little brass cymbals, and they were singing the same eight words over and over in the hot dusk, and the people coming out of the movie house walked around them as if they were a fire hydrant. Margaret stood and listened until they stopped. She went to the temple on Sunday for the feast. She went the next Sunday and

the next. In the spring she sat down across the kitchen table from her husband and asked him, the way she had asked her parents, if she could go.

Doug Pruitt thought about it for three days. Then he said yes, because he could see that she would die a little every day if he said no, and he was not that kind of man. He drove her to the temple himself on a Saturday morning in May, in his father's Buick with the top down, with her three suitcases in the back and her mother's silver tea service wrapped in towels for a gift, and he carried the suitcases up the steps and shook hands with the temple president, and kissed her on the forehead in front of everybody, and drove away. She did not know, and he did not know, that she was six weeks pregnant.

The temple was an old two-story house on a street of old houses north of downtown, with a peeling porch and a smell of incense and ghee and cooking rice that you could smell from the corner. Margaret was given a sari, and a bed on the floor of the women's ashram upstairs with nine other women, and a string of a hundred and eight wooden beads to chant on, and a name. They called her Kunti.

She rose at three-thirty with the others and bathed in cold water and went down for the morning service in the dark. She chanted her rounds. She cut vegetables. In the afternoons she went out with the women in the van to sell the books, in parking lots and on the campus and at the airport, in the heat, and she was good at it, because she had been raised to talk to anybody and she was not afraid of anybody. She was happy. She had not known it was possible to be so happy.

In August the other women noticed she was showing.

Kunti. What does this mean?

She looked down at herself as if it were somebody else's body. *I don't know what it means. But I know I've kept my vows. Every one.*

The women took her to the temple president. He was a young man from Ohio named Balabhadra who ran the temple as well as anybody ran anything in those years, and better than most; he had paid off the mortgage and doubled the book sales and kept three of his devotees out of the hands of the deprogrammers whom their parents had hired. The newspa-

pers called them a cult. The parents' groups held meetings at churches in Scottsdale and passed out pamphlets about brainwashing. Balabhadra had been on the evening news twice that year, defending the temple, and he thought about the evening news all the time.

He did not ask Kunti anything. He thought only of what the newspapers would do with a pregnant Hare Krishna nun.

She has to go, he said. *Today. Call her husband.*

Kunti stood up. *Prabhu, please don't ruin me. I didn't come here for you. I came for Krishna. Take me to Maharaj at the grove.*

II. The Curtain

The grove on the Salt River · August 1973

The devotees had a farm east of the city on the Salt River, twelve acres of old orange grove that a widow in Mesa had left them, with a farmhouse and a cow barn and an irrigation ditch and a pump house under the tamarisks. Four cows lived there, and a dozen men, and a sannyasi the devotees called Maharaj.

He had been born Ellis Batiste in a sugarcane parish in Louisiana in 1931. He had been a cook in the Navy, and a merchant seaman, and a short-order cook in San Francisco, where in the winter of 1967 he had walked into a storefront on Frederick Street to get out of the rain and heard an old man from India explain the Bhagavad Gita to twenty hippies. He was forty-two now. He was a big man, with a grey beard cut close and a deep voice that he rarely raised and rarely used. The devotees in the city said he did not have a head for management. The devotees at the grove said nothing, but when somebody in the movement was in real trouble, sooner or later they ended up at the grove.

He listened to the women from the temple tell it on the porch of the farmhouse. He looked at Kunti for a long time. Then he asked a few things that only a man who had grown up in a house with five sisters would have known to ask, and he knew.

But knowing was not enough. The newspapers would not take his word for it, or hers.

So on the next Sunday he sent for everybody. He sent for Mr. R. K. Bhattacharya, who had been an engineer at Motorola and now owned forty acres of Scottsdale that were worth more every month, and who was the temple's biggest life member. He sent for Mr. and Mrs. Iyer, and old Mr. Sandhu who had the motel on Van Buren, and the Methodist minister from Mesa who sometimes came to the Sunday feast for the food. He sent for Dr. Leela Menon, from Kerala, who had delivered half the Indian babies in the Valley of the Sun and had seven grandchildren of her own and was afraid of nobody on earth. He sent for Balabhadra. And he sent for Purushottam, the head pujari of the city temple, who had been a barber in Glendale before he joined and who knew the rule book better than anybody in Arizona, and told him to clear the girl in front of everybody.

Purushottam put the case in Dr. Menon's hands. In the big front room of the farmhouse the women hung four saris on a clothesline from wall to wall, and behind the saris Dr. Menon examined Kunti: her hands and her feet, her eyes, her belly, the height of the womb. Then she asked her the date of her last period, and the date she had come to the temple, and the date her husband had driven away in the Buick, and she counted it out on her fingers and then on a prescription pad, months and weeks and days, and came out from behind the saris and told Purushottam.

Purushottam stood up on a chair in front of a hundred and forty people at the Sunday feast and said it in a loud voice, so that the Methodist minister could hear, and the life members, and Balabhadra at the back. *This child was conceived while our sister was a married woman living with her husband. Her vows are unbroken. There is nothing to say against her. Nothing.*

The baby came the next February, at the grove, in the back bedroom of the farmhouse, with Dr. Menon there. A boy, nine pounds, with a great deal of black hair, who came out yelling.

III. Raja

Paradise Valley · 1974–1984

One afternoon in March Mr. Bhattacharya came out to the grove about a donation and, walking past the farmhouse to his car, heard a baby crying.

What's that?

That's Kunti's boy, Prabhu. The one from the curtain.

Mr. Bhattacharya stood on the path for a while. He had three daughters and no son, and his wife had died two years before. He went and talked to Maharaj in the cow barn. And at the end of the week he came back with his three daughters in the Mercedes and took the boy home with him to Paradise Valley, a mile from the house Kunti had grown up in, and gave him to the girls to raise.

Kunti let him go. She told herself that it was Krishna's arrangement, and that a woman who had taken vows had no business with a baby, and that he would have everything in that house that she could never give him. All of it was true. She went back to the city temple, and that summer she joined one of the women's traveling parties that went around the country in a van selling the books, and she was gone for years.

The Bhattacharyas named the boy Kashyap, after a sage, at a naming ceremony with a priest and two hundred guests and a cake from the Biltmore. Nobody ever called him that. The daughters called him Raja, because they treated him like one, and the name stuck, and by the time he was in school the whole of Paradise Valley called him Raja Bhattacharya, the little prince, the white boy with the Indian father and the Mercedes and the three sisters who did his homework.

When he was ten he hit a boy on the playground at school, hard, over a basketball, and the boy and his friends yelled after him, *You don't even have a mom! You don't have a real dad! You're adopted!*

He went home and found Mr. Bhattacharya in his study.

Baba, they say I don't have a mother or a father. Who's my mother?

Mr. Bhattacharya pointed through the study door at his daughters, who were at the kitchen counter, arguing. *There are your mothers.*

I can't have that many mothers. I'm supposed to have one. Tell me who she is.

Mr. Bhattacharya looked at him for a long time and understood that he could not fool this boy and never would be able to.

Your mother is a devotee, Raja. A Hare Krishna. A good one. I brought you home from the grove on the Salt River when you were six weeks old.

It was all the boy needed. Something went through him, standing there on the carpet, that he could not have explained to anybody. *Baba, take me there. I want to go there. I want to live there.*

Mr. Bhattacharya said, *All right, Raja.*

He did it properly. He took the boy out to the grove on a Sunday in the Mercedes with all three daughters crying in the back seat and a second car behind them full of sweets for the feast, two hundred pounds of them, and he gave the boy into the hands of Maharaj in front of everybody. The boy lived at the grove from then on, with the men, and went to the public school in Mesa on the bus, and Mr. Bhattacharya paid for everything. When he was eighteen Maharaj gave him the brahmachari's vows and the saffron cloth, and he shaved his head except for the little tuft at the back, and he was called Kashyap Das. He was a monk now, the way his mother had been a nun.

He had asked about her, of course. Maharaj told him she was on the road and that he would meet her when it was time, and not before, and the boy, who was not used to being told no, found to his own surprise that he did not argue.

IV. Fifteen Questions

The pump house · 1993–1995

Maharaj gave him a practice and he took it to India. He went to Vrindavan, where Krishna had been a cowherd boy, and lived in a room by the Yamuna for a year and a half and chanted sixty-four rounds a day and fasted on the holy days and walked the circuit of Govardhan Hill barefoot in the summer heat, and he got nowhere. He could feel himself

GETTING NOWHERE. IT WAS LIKE PUSHING ON A DOOR THAT opened the other way.

So he came home to the grove. *I need something else, Maharaj. What you gave me was too big for me, or too small.* Maharaj looked at him and told him to live in the pump house for a while, under the tamarisks at the back of the property where it was dark even at noon, and keep chanting, and wait.

In March of 1995, in the pump house, a visitor came. What Kashyap told about it afterward, and never changed in the telling, was that he woke in the middle of the night and an old man in white was sitting on the floor by his mat, a babaji with a white beard and the clay marks of the Vaishnavas on his forehead and his nose, very thin, very old, who said he had done his chanting alone in a cave on Govardhan Hill for longer than anybody now living could remember, and had come a long way. The old man asked him fifteen questions. They were like riddles.

There is an anthill. At night it smokes. In the day it blazes. A brahmin says to a wise man, Take a knife and dig. The wise man digs and finds a bar across the way. Throw out the bar, says the brahmin. Dig. He digs and finds a toad. Throw out the toad. Dig. He finds a fork in the road, and a sieve, and a tortoise, and an axe and a chopping block, and a piece of meat. Throw them out, dig. And at the bottom he finds a cobra. Leave the cobra, says the brahmin. Do not harm him. Bow down to him.

What is the anthill? What is the smoke? What is the blaze? Who is the brahmin, who is the wise man, what is the knife, what is the digging, what is the bar, what is the toad, the fork, the sieve, the tortoise, the axe and the block, the piece of meat, the cobra?

I can't answer them, Kashyap said.

No. Only your teacher can answer them. Go and ask him.

In the morning there was nobody there. There were the marks of bare feet in the dust of the pump house floor, going to the door, and none going away from it.

He went to Maharaj in the cow barn and asked him the fifteen questions in order, and Maharaj, milking, answered them in order, without looking up from the cow. The anthill is this body, that your mother made

and rice and milk keep up. The smoke at night is what you think over in the dark. The blaze in the day is what you go out and do about it. The brahmin is your teacher. The wise man is you. The knife is knowing the difference. The digging is your effort. The bar is not knowing. The toad is anger. The fork in the road is doubt. The sieve, the five things that strain a mind and leave nothing in it. The tortoise, the five places where you keep yourself, and pull your head and feet back into when you are afraid. The axe and the block, the things you want, that cut you up. The piece of meat, the wanting itself, delight and greed. *And the cobra,* Maharaj said, and stopped milking for a moment, *is what's left when you've dug all of that out. Leave him be. Bow down to him. That's you, at the bottom. That was always you.*

Kashyap sat on an upturned bucket in the barn and listened, and when Maharaj finished, it was done. The devotees who were there said he did not look any different, only that from then on, whenever you looked at him, he seemed to be already sitting down, even when he was walking.

V. The Parking Lot

Mesa · June 1996

For twelve years, from the day the Mercedes took her son out to the grove, Kunti had cried. She cried on the road in the van, between Albuquerque and Amarillo and Tulsa. She cried at the morning service with her face to the wall. She cried in parking lots and airports and on college campuses, holding out the books to strangers with tears running down her face, so that people gave her money just to make her stop, and the other women said she was the best book distributor in the movement and did not know why. She chanted her rounds, sixteen a day, twenty-three years of them, and her face was always wet. Every Christmas Mr. Bhattacharya's eldest daughter sent her a photograph, to whatever temple she was at, and she had them in a tin box: a baby, a boy on a bicycle, a boy in a school blazer, a tall thin young man with a shaved head in saffron cloth.

In June of 1996 the traveling party came back through Phoenix, and on a Thursday afternoon at four o'clock, at a hundred and fifteen degrees, Kunti was standing in the parking lot of a supermarket on Main Street in Mesa with an armful of books, when a young brahmachari in saffron cloth came across the asphalt from the other side, carrying a cardboard box, with two other men from the grove.

She knew him from forty yards away.

My son, she said. *My son. My son.* And she dropped the books and ran.

The people who were loading groceries into their cars said afterward that they had never seen anything like it. A woman of forty-four in a white sari ran across the parking lot, in that heat, and threw herself down at the young monk's feet on the asphalt, which was hot enough to blister, and rolled there, crying, holding his ankles. And her milk came. Twenty-two years after she had nursed him, the milk ran out of her and soaked the front of her sari through, and she got up off the ground with it running down her and put her arms around him and held on.

Kashyap stood very still with the box in his arms. He knew what she was. He had known since he was ten. And he thought: if I am kind to her now, it will finish her. She will hang on to this for the rest of her life, and it will drown her.

So he said, coldly, in a voice she had never heard from anyone at the temple, *Mataji, what are you doing? Can't you give up this bodily attachment?*

She let go of him and stepped back and looked at him, and the thought that went through her head, then and there, was that he talked like a deprogrammer. Like one of those men in the vans who used to grab the devotees off the street and drive them to motels and keep them there for days, yelling at them, until they broke.

My son, what did you say?

He said it again. And then, because she was still standing there with her arms half up, he said the thing that Krishna says first to Arjuna on the battlefield, the very first thing, to a man who is weeping for his family.

> *Thou grievest for those that should not be grieved for, yet speakest words of wisdom. The wise grieve neither for the living nor for the dead.*
>
> *— Bhagavad Gita 2:11, tr. Annie Besant (1896)*

Kunti stood in the parking lot with the sun coming up off the asphalt in waves, and the milk going sticky on her sari, and her son in front of her, and she thought: Twelve years I have cried for this boy. Twelve years I have not been able to stop. And he has hardened his heart. Why should I carry him one more step?

And she put him down. She felt it go, the way you feel a heavy box go when somebody finally takes the other end, and then nobody is holding the other end, and it is just gone. She bent down and picked up her books off the asphalt. Her face was dry. It was the first time in twelve years her face had been dry, and it stayed that way for the rest of her life.

The two men from the grove said that she went back to her table by the supermarket door and stood there with the books and smiled at the people coming out, and that a man pushing a cart full of beer gave her a twenty-dollar bill without being asked, and that Kashyap Das stood in the middle of the parking lot holding his cardboard box and watched her for a long time before he went on.

VI. The White Buck

The grove · autumn 1996

The story went around the movement the way stories did, from temple to temple, and by the fall it had come back to the grove. One evening, after the class on the porch, the men were talking about it in the dark, with the swamp cooler going.

Balabhadra almost finished them both, one of them said. *Her and the boy. Before he was even born. And Maharaj was their shelter, both times.*

Maharaj came out onto the porch with a glass of water and sat down on the step.

That's not the first time, he said. *Let me tell you something from home.*

When I was a boy in St. Mary Parish, he said, the man who owned the land we lived on loved to hunt more than anything in the world. He had his supper off venison every night of the season. And every week he called out every man on the place to drive deer for him, so nobody could get his own work done, until the men got together and said, Let's fence a piece of the swamp and drive the deer into it, and he can shoot them there and leave us alone. So they did. They went out with sticks and pans and beat the woods for miles and drove every deer in the country into that fence.

There were two white bucks in the drive. Pure white, with pink eyes. The old people said it was bad luck to shoot a white deer, and the landowner believed it, so he said those two were never to be touched. All the rest he shot whenever he pleased, and they ran from him and got wounded and ran and got wounded again until they dropped.

So the older of the white bucks went to the younger one and said, Brother, they're going to die anyway. Let's not have them shot to pieces running. Let one go down to the gate every morning and stand still and be taken. One day from your herd, one day from mine. And that is how they did it.

Then the turn came to a doe in the younger buck's herd who was heavy with a fawn. She went to him and said, Let me pass this once. When the fawn's born there'll be two of us to take a turn. And he said, No. I can't put your turn on anybody else. Go on. So she went to the old white buck, and he said, Go on home. I'll see to it. And in the morning he went down to the gate himself and stood still to be taken.

The man who did the shooting ran up to the house and got the landowner, and the landowner came down in his truck, and stood there with his rifle and looked at the white buck standing at the gate.

Didn't I say you were safe? What are you doing down here?

And the buck told him. And the landowner, said Maharaj, who was not a man anybody on that place had ever seen moved by anything, put the rifle down, and said, I'll spare you, and her. And the buck said, What about the rest of them in the fence? And the man said, All right, them too. What about the deer in the woods? Them too. What about the rab-

bits and the coons and the birds? Them too. And the fish in the bayou? And the man laughed out loud, they said, standing there in the mud, and said, All right. Them too.

He drank his water.

That doe had her fawn that spring, he said. *And the old women on our place used to tell it to us children when we were small: Stay with the white buck. Better to die with the white buck than live with the other one.*

Nobody on the porch said anything. The swamp cooler ran. Then one of the young men asked about Kunti, and whether it had been right, what Kashyap did to her in the parking lot, and Maharaj was quiet for a while.

She did that herself, he said. *He didn't do it. I didn't do it. What one person works out, nobody can hand to anybody else, not a son to a mother, not a mother to a son. She was her own shelter. That's the only kind there is. It's hard to find, and she found it.* And he said the verse from the Gita that they all knew, that says it better than he could.

> *Let him raise the self by the Self, and not let the self become depressed; for verily is the Self the friend of the self, and also the Self the self's enemy; The Self is the friend of the self of him in whom the self by the Self is vanquished; but to the unsubdued self, the self verily becometh hostile as an enemy.*
>
> *— Bhagavad Gita 6:5–6, tr. Annie Besant (1896)*

• • •

Kunti came out to the grove at Janmashtami the next August, for Krishna's birthday, with the women from the traveling party, and cooked for the feast in the farmhouse kitchen where her son had been born. She cooked for three hundred people. Kashyap Das served it, going down the long rows of devotees and guests sitting on the ground under the orange trees with a bucket of rice and a ladle, and when he came to his mother he put the rice on her leaf plate the same as on everybody else's, and she said, *Thank you, Prabhu,* the same as everybody else, and he went on down the row.

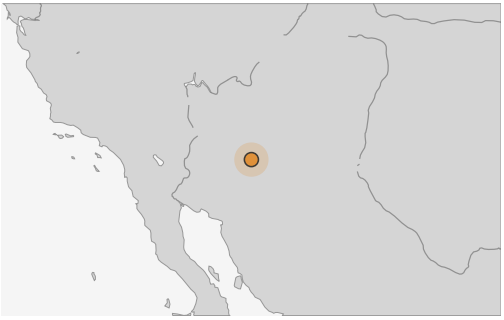
Mr. Bhattacharya's eldest daughter was there, and saw it, and could not stand it, and said so to Kunti afterward at the wash basins. Kunti only laughed, and shook the water off her hands, and went back to the kitchen to do the pots. And under the orange trees, a little apart from the rows, in the long gold light of an August evening in the desert, a white cow from the barn was going along with her calf, eating what the guests had left.

Background

The verse

> *Self is the lord of self, who else could be the lord? With self well subdued, a man finds a lord such as few can find.*
>
> Dhammapada 160, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich man's daughter who has longed all her life to become a nun is finally allowed to by her husband, and goes forth among the nuns of Devadatta's faction without knowing she is pregnant. When it shows, Devadatta orders her expelled to protect his reputation; she appeals to the Buddha, who has the laywoman Visākhā examine her behind a curtain and count the months, and the elder Upāli declares her innocent before the whole assembly. King Pasenadi hears the baby crying, takes him home to be raised by his daughters, and the boy, Kumāra Kassapa ("Prince Kassapa"), learns from playground taunts that he has a mother among the nuns and asks to be ordained. After failing to progress in the forest, he is set fifteen riddles by a visitor from the Brahma world, and attains arahatship when the Buddha answers them. Twelve years after he left the world, his mother, who has wept all that time, sees him in the street and runs to him with her milk flowing; he speaks harshly to her on purpose, and she lets go of her attachment and is freed. The Buddha then tells the birth story of the banyan deer, who offered his own life in place of a pregnant doe. Read the full commentary story, or about Kumāra Kassapa.



Phoenix and Mesa, Arizona

The Hare Krishnas in Arizona, *1973–1996*

The International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) was founded in New York City in July 1966 by A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami, and in January 1967 he opened a storefront temple on Frederick Street in San Francisco's Haight-Ashbury. Its devotees chanted in the streets, held free Sunday feasts, and funded the movement by selling its books, first on sidewalks and campuses and then in airports and other public places; courts generally upheld their right to do so under the First Amendment. Its central scripture is the Bhagavad Gita, which the story quotes in the 1896 translation by Annie Besant, rather than the movement's own.

In the 1970s, as new religious movements spread, many parents of young converts hired deprogrammers, whose methods often amounted to kidnapping and false imprisonment; the best known, Ted Patrick, was eventually convicted of felonies for it. Kunti, Kashyap, Maharaj, the grove on the Salt River and the Phoenix temple in the story are fictional.

After the story of the mother of Kumāra Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 160). The original. Scripture from the Bhagavad Gita, translated by Annie Besant (1896). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

12.5

The Imposing Stone

> *If destruction be our lot we must ourselves be its author and finisher.*
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Address before the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield, 1838*

The way it was handed to me, in a printing office at Springfield.

I. Press Night

Springfield, Illinois · Friday, February 2, 1838

The Journal came out on Saturdays, so Friday was press night, and on press night the office was the one lit window in that part of town. Lew Carmody was fifteen and in the second year of a five-year indenture. The other apprentice, Hod, was twelve and had been bound since October. Between them they carried the wood and the water, damped the paper, rolled the ink, washed the forms in lye and swept up after, and for this they were called devils, as boys in printing offices had been called for two hundred years.

The foreman was Mr. Abner Pell. He was a Vermonter of about forty, stooped from the case, who had set type in eleven towns between Brattleboro and the Sangamon. He could read a line of type upside down and backward faster than Lew could read it off the sheet. He seldom said anything in the shop that was not about the work.

There was a fourth person in the office that night, and he did not work there. Jesse Odom had come up from Mississippi a year and a half before with a wagon and two mules, and he cut and hauled stove wood for half the square. He was a big man past forty, slow to speak, who signed for his money with a mark. His first winter in town he had brought a load to the

office on a press night and stood by the stove while a proof was read. A proof has to be read aloud against the copy, a boy calling out the words and the points while the foreman follows on the damp slip with a pen. Odom had stayed until it was done. After that he came every Friday. He sat on the wood box with his hat on his knee and heard the canal reports and the acts of the legislature and the notices of strayed horses, and when the press was working he fed the stove. Mr. Pell let him stay. Nobody had asked him why he wanted to.

The long piece that week was an address. A young lawyer in Mr. Stuart's office, a long, dark man, had read it out to the Young Men's Lyceum at the Baptist church the Saturday before, and it ran to better than three columns. Mr. Pell had set most of it himself. A little after nine Hod got up on a box under the lamp with the copy and began to read, and Mr. Pell followed him with the pen.

It was about the laws, and what becomes of a country where men leave off keeping them. Hod read it the way he read everything, at a trot. He came to a place about the State of Mississippi.

> *Thus went on this process of hanging, from gamblers to negroes, from negroes to white citizens, and from these to strangers, till dead men were seen literally dangling from the boughs of trees upon every roadside, and in numbers almost sufficient to rival the native Spanish moss of the country as a drapery of the forest.*
>
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Address before the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield, January 27, 1838*

Read that over, Odom said.

He had never spoken during a proof. Hod looked at Mr. Pell, and Mr. Pell nodded, and Hod went back a few lines and read it over. Odom did not ask again. But Lew, turning paper at the bank, saw that he had put his hat down on the floor.

They locked up the form a little before eleven and began to work it off, Lew at the bar and Hod with the roller. A hand press is loud enough that two people at the far end of a room can talk and not be heard. Sometime

after one Lew looked up between pulls and saw Odom standing with Mr. Pell at the imposing stone under the back window. The foreman's head was down. The big man's mouth was moving. It went on for the length of a candle.

Once Odom took something from inside his shirt and held it to the light, and it flashed like a drop of water. He turned and drew his hand down the windowpane. Lew heard that through the press, a squeal like a slate pencil. Then the hand moved toward the stone, and Mr. Pell laid his own palm flat on the marble and said something short. Odom put the thing back in his shirt.

The last sheet came off a while before first light. Odom took a bucket, as he did every week, and went out to the well in the lot behind the office to wash before he saw to his mules.

II. The Well

The lot behind the office · first light

What happened at the well Lew had afterward from four or five men who were in it, and they all told it alike.

Sometime past five, three men got into Ruggles's store on the square by a back shutter. Mr. Ruggles slept over the store. He woke when a brass kettle came down off its hook, and he went down the stair in his shirt with a fowling piece that was not loaded, and the three went out the way they had come with a meal sack between them. He raised the street. By the corner there were ten or a dozen men behind the thieves: his two clerks, a smith, some teamsters who had been harnessing in the tavern yard. The thieves threw down a bolt of calico in the mud, and then a caddy of tea, and the men behind ran past both. At the next corner the three split. One of them came up the lot behind the printing office with the sack. He saw a big man bent over a bucket at the well with his face in his hands, and he slung the sack down at the man's feet and went over the fence.

The others came into the lot with one lantern. What they saw was a man straightening up from a bucket with water running off his chin, and Ruggles's sack at his boots with the kettle half out of it.

Some of them knew him. *It's the wood hauler,* a clerk said. *The Mississippian.*

Odom said he had been in the printing office since dark. He said he had been hearing a piece read.

Hearing a piece read, Ruggles said. *I have your mark on my book, Odom. You can't read your own name. You broke my shutter, and here you stand washing as if you'd been at meeting.*

They went through his coat. Inside his shirt, pinned in a twist of rag, they found a breastpin, a diamond the size of a field pea in a gold claw. Ruggles held it up to the lantern. He did not deal in such goods and it was no part of what he had lost. But every man in the lot knew what to think of a wood hauler with a stone like that on him.

That's mine, Odom said. *I've had that nine years.*

He said it twice more. It was the truth, and each time it sounded worse. Somebody had pulled a stick of stove wood off the pile by the office door. It was Odom's own cutting, hickory, split in the fall. Then several of them had sticks. He was a strong man and it took some time. He never called out to the printers, though the window was thirty feet off and lit. One of the teamsters said that toward the end he let his arms come down from his head, and that he seemed to be studying them, one face and then the next, like a man who has been told to expect somebody.

When he had stopped moving they stood back. It was getting light enough to see each other by. They dragged him by the heels to the side of the lot, in under the fence where the hogs had rooted, and they took up the sack and went back to the square to look for the other two.

A quarter of an hour later Lew and Hod came out with the buckets for water to wash the form. Hod saw the boots.

III. What He Told

The Journal office · sunup

Mr. Pell went out and looked and came back in. He washed his hands at the bucket and dried them on his apron.

He was here, Mr. Pell, Lew said. *He never went out but for wood. He was on that box from dark till the last sheet. He didn't do a thing.*

He did nothing last night. I will swear to that in front of anybody, and so will you. Sit down, both of you.

They sat down on the wood box. The whole edition was stacked on the bank with the lawyer's address on the second page, dry enough to fold. Mr. Pell stood at the imposing stone with his back to the window.

I am going to tell you what he told me at this stone between one o'clock and two. Then you will know as much as I do.

IV. The Big Black

Madison County, Mississippi · July 1835

In the summer of 1835 Jesse Odom kept a ferry on the Big Black River in Madison County, on a road going north out of Livingston toward the Yazoo. He had a flat on a rope, a house with two rooms for travelers, and one man, named Harry, whom he owned, who worked the rope.

At the end of June a planter's wife up at Beattie's Bluff believed she had heard her house servants whispering about a rising set for the Fourth of July. Within a week every beat in the county had its committee. They put the black men of the Bluff plantations to the question with the whip and hanged five of them, an old preacher among the five who had said nothing under it. At Livingston the same week they hanged two white men, steam doctors, from the grating of the jail window. The talk was that a clan of land pirates stood behind the whole of it, and that their captains were riding the roads in the character of travelers. Every stranger bound north had to come down to Odom's landing, so the committee made him captain of patrol for his beat. No one crossed without

giving an account of himself. Beyond the river the road ran four miles through cane, and for a dollar Odom or one of his patrol would ride a traveler through to the far side.

Late one afternoon that week a gig came down to the landing. The man driving it was young, a Tennessean, a saddler by his hands, on his way to a brother who had entered land on the Yazoo. His wife sat beside him. She wore a green calash against the sun, and when the gig stopped she pushed it back.

Odom told Mr. Pell he had seen handsome women before that day and could not account for it. He wanted her. And he had seen in that same minute how it could be managed, because that week, in that county, it was the easiest thing in the world to manage.

The Tennessean asked to be put across and ridden through the cane.

It's too late in the day, Odom said. *I'll take you through at sunup.*

There's two hours of light yet, sir. We would be obliged to go on.

You'll turn back to the house. There's supper there and a bed.

The young man said again that he would rather go on. Odom lifted one hand, and two of the patrol took the mare by the cheek strap and turned the gig around in the road.

He gave them the better room and had a hen killed. At the table Odom kept his eyes on his plate.

Odom owned a breastpin, a diamond in a gold claw, which a gambler at Natchez had put up against a debt in the year 1829 and never come back for. When the house was dark he gave it to Harry and told him to put it under the cushion of the gig seat. Harry put it there. That summer a black man in Madison County did what a captain of patrol told him, and did it quickly.

At first light one of the patrol fired a pistol behind the house and hollered thief. Then he came around to the gallery and said, good and loud, *Captain, your pin's gone out of the press.* Odom gave out that no one was to cross, and that nothing on wheels was to come down to the landing without being gone through.

The Tennessean had his mare in the shafts by sunup. They stopped him at the top of the bank. Harry had been told he would be the one to find it, and he put his hand under the cushion and found it.

Here's a man eats your chicken and sleeps in your bed, one of the patrol said, *and drives off before breakfast with your diamond.*

They pulled him down over the wheel and beat him in the road. Then they tied him behind a horse and took him a mile to the house of the planter who sat as the committee for that beat. The Squire heard it from his chair on the gallery.

After my friend Odom had lodged him, and fed him, the Squire said. *We know what kind is on the roads this week. Take him off, gentlemen.*

That was the whole trial. In that week nobody looked for more. They asked him under the whip to name his confederates in the clan. He had none to name, and he had been dead some little time before they took notice of it. They put him in the Big Black.

The woman had sat through all of it in the gig at the top of the bank, with the reins in her lap. Afterward Odom went up to her with his hat off and told her she was welcome to stay at the ferry house until her people could be written to.

Put my mare on your boat, she said.

Harry took her over. She drove into the cane alone, and Odom never learned whether she came out at the other end of it. That evening the Squire's son brought the pin down to the ferry with the Squire's compliments.

He kept the ferry one year more. Before he left he sold Harry at Vicksburg, because he could not stand to have him by, and he told Mr. Pell that he had known what that was while he was doing it. He had not slept a night through since that July. It was why he sat up Fridays. A room with a lamp in it and somebody reading was the one place he had found where the dark went by. He had come north because he heard there was law in the free states, and in every town on the way he had looked at the men standing about the tavern doors and thought, it will be these. In Springfield he had about quit looking.

He asked me a thing, Mr. Pell said. *When Hod read out the Mississippi part, he knew every tree in it. He asked me did the piece say what comes to the men who do such work. I told him it said something. I read it to him off the proof.*

The slip was in his apron. He read it to the two boys as he had read it to Odom, flat, the way he read copy.

> *When men take it in their heads to-day to hang gamblers or burn murderers, they should recollect that in the confusion usually attending such transactions they will be as likely to hang or burn some one who is neither a gambler nor a murderer as one who is, and that, acting upon the example they set, the mob of to-morrow may, and probably will, hang or burn some of them by the very same mistake.*
>
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Address before the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield, January 27, 1838*

He had me read it twice. Then he took out the pin, to show me it was a true stone. He said it would write on anything in this shop, and he wrote on my window with it. He'd have tried the stone next. Mr. Pell put his palm on the marble, as he had in the night. *Hod, go and fetch Mr. Francis. Lew, get your coat. You and I are going to the justice.*

• • •

The paper went out that morning as it stood. There was no time to open a form for a death behind the office, and so the address against mobs was carried around Springfield by a boy who had found the body.

The coroner's jury sat on Monday. Mr. Pell swore that Jesse Odom had been in the office from dark until first light, and both apprentices swore it after him. One of the three thieves was taken that week on the Jacksonville road with a kettle of Ruggles's on his saddle. The jury found that Odom had come to his death by blows from persons unknown, and there was not a man on it who could not have named six of them. Ruggles gave the breastpin over to the coroner with his own hand. It was sold at vendue in April, with the wagon and the mules, to a drover who was going to Texas.

On Tuesday the boys washed the form, and Mr. Pell unlocked it on the stone, and they threw the address back into the cases a letter at a time. That is how it goes in a printing office. By the next Friday the same m and o and b had gone out again in a notice of bottom land for sale.

The scratch stayed in the window. It ran a hand's length down the lower pane, a little out of true. On a clear morning, when the sun got over the roofs across the lot, it laid one bright hair across the imposing stone and across whatever was locked up on it. Lew Carmody worked at that stone four more years. He had apprentices of his own afterward, in Peoria and then in Iowa, and he told them he had never known a clear morning when the line did not come, and that Mr. Pell would not have the pane changed.

Background

The verse

> *The evil done by oneself, self-begotten, self-bred, crushes the foolish, as a diamond breaks a precious stone.*
>
> Dhammapada 161, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the layman Mahā Kāla ("Big Black") keeps the observance day and sits up the whole night at the monastery listening to the teaching. Toward dawn, thieves running from a house they have robbed throw their loot down in front of him as he washes his face at the monastery pool. The owners come up, tell him he has only been acting the part of a man who listens to the Dhamma, and beat him to death, and the young monks find his body when they go out with their water pots. The Buddha grants that in this life he did nothing to earn it. Then he tells of an earlier one, in which the same man was a king's soldier posted at a forest road, wanted a traveler's wife, had his own jewel hidden in the traveler's carriage and found there, and saw the man beaten to death on the word of the village headman. Read the full commentary story. A later story in the same chapter begins the same way and ends differently; this series tells it as Windmill Water.

Springfield, Illinois

Springfield, 1838, and the Big Black, 1835

On January 27, 1838, Abraham Lincoln, twenty-eight years old and the junior partner in John T. Stuart's law office, read an address called "The Perpetuation of Our Political Institutions" to the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield, which met in the Baptist church. Its subject was mob law. The Sangamo Journal, the Whig weekly that Simeon Francis had edited since 1831, printed it on February 3. See Lincoln's Lyceum address; the passages quoted here follow the text in Arthur Brooks Lapsley's edition of the Papers and Writings (1905). A country paper of that day was set by hand and worked off on a hand press. Proofs were read aloud against the copy, the type was thrown back into the cases afterward to be used again, and the apprentices were called devils. The imposing stone is the flat slab on which pages of type are locked into their iron frame. Mr. Pell, the two apprentices, Jesse Odom, Ruggles and his store, and the killing behind the office are invented. No such death is recorded at Springfield that morning.

The Mississippi that Lincoln described was two and a half years old. Late in June 1835 a rumor went through Madison County that the enslaved people of the plantations around Beattie's Bluff, on the Big Black River, meant to rise on the Fourth of July, led by white outlaws of the kind a new pamphlet had attached to the name of John Murrell. Self-appointed committees there and at Livingston questioned black men under the lash and hanged a number of them. They also hanged several white men, among them two "steam doctors," itinerant botanic practitioners, from the grating of the Livingston jail window. In the same week a crowd at Vicksburg hanged five gamblers. Travelers and newcomers were the first white men suspected. The ferry, its captain of patrol, the Squire and the couple from Tennessee are invented.

After the story of the lay disciple Mahā Kāla from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 161). The original. Words from Abraham Lincoln's address before the Young Men's Lyceum of Springfield (1838). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

12.6

Strangler Fig

Whoso diggeth a pit shall fall therein: and he that rolleth a stone, it will return upon him.
— Proverbs 26:27

This is how they tell it, on Halfmoon Key.

I. The Splinter

Halfmoon Key, Ten Thousand Islands, Florida · April 1910

Halfmoon Key was an old shell heap the Indians had left, nobody knew how long ago, the highest ground for ten miles in any direction, which is to say about the height of a man on a man's shoulders. Six families lived on it in houses up on cypress blocks. They fished mullet and crabbed and cut buttonwood for charcoal and grew a little cane and tomatoes on the top of the mound, and on the north side, where the landing was, an old gumbo limbo leaned out over the water with its red bark peeling like a sunburn and a strangler fig wrapped around it from the crown to the roots.

Retta Sweeting had her husband's foot in her lap on the porch with a lamp on the floor and a darning needle she had held in the flame. The men sat along the porch rail, Lige Daniels and the two Whidden boys and old Cyrus Kirk, who could not hear but liked to be where talk was. The children were supposed to be asleep and were under the house.

The splinter was cypress, from the gunwale of Ez's skiff, and it had gone in under the arch of his foot an inch and a half. The bullet that sent it there had come out of the mangroves at the mouth of Plover Creek that morning while he was poling through on the falling tide, and had hit the gunwale a hand's width from his knee. He had poled the eleven miles

home with the splinter in his foot, and then he had gone back down to the landing to bail, because the skiff had taken water, and Retta had told the men to sit down and wait for him, and they had.

It was Duke, Lige said.

Nobody said it was not.

II. The Talk on the Porch

The same night

THEY HAD BEEN TALKING ABOUT DUKE SWEETING FOR MOST OF a year, and they talked about him again now, the whole of it from the beginning, the way people will go back over a thing that has hurt them.

Duke and Ez were first cousins, raised in the same house on Pine Island after Duke's mother died, and Ez had married Duke's sister. When they were boys they had shot plumes together, every spring, in the rookeries up Lostmans River and back in the Big Cypress, when the white birds were nesting and the long feathers grew down their backs. A good day's shooting then could bring more money than a man made in a season of fishing. The buyers paid by the ounce, and in the best years the ounce of plumes was worth more than the ounce of gold.

Then one spring Ez had gone back into a rookery a week after they had shot it out, by himself, nobody ever knew what for. He came out and did not talk for two days. Lige was with him in the boat afterward and said all Ez ever told him was that the young ones were still in the nests, hollering, and there was nobody to feed them, and some of them were hanging over the edge. Ez never fired another shot at a bird. When the Audubon people were hiring wardens after the new law, he went up to Fort Myers and signed on for thirty-five dollars a month, and Duke laughed at him for it, and then quit laughing.

Duke could do anything. He could shoot the eye out of a crane at sixty yards, and dance, and talk a buyer up two dollars an ounce, and the young men followed him around the islands. People liked Duke, and Duke could not stand that people liked Ez better.

The store on Halfmoon belonged to old Captain Lucius Roberts, and he had bought plumes thirty years. He weighed them on a brass postal scale on the counter and paid cash out of a cigar box. In 1906, the year after the warden at Flamingo was shot dead for trying to stop a man and his sons at a rookery, the Captain had sat a long evening on this same porch with Ez, and nobody knew what was said. In the morning he put up a sign in the store that he did not buy plumes anymore. After that he kept the warden's skiff in tar and canvas out of his own pocket and gave Ez a can of coffee every month, and said he was too old to be ashamed of anything but what he had already done.

His son Cal was a grown man and wanted the store, and wanted it the way it had been. Duke got hold of Cal. It was Duke who said the old man was not right in his head anymore, giving away goods, talking to a game warden all night, and it was Duke who rode up with Cal to Fort Myers to see the doctors and the judge. In the spring of 1909 they took Captain Roberts away to the state asylum at Chattahoochee, in a clean shirt, with his hat on his knee in the boat. He did not want to go and he did not fight. He died there before Christmas. They said he would not eat.

Now the cigar box was back on the counter, and the brass scale, and Cal paid thirty dollars an ounce, and Duke brought in more plumes than anybody. And Duke had told it in the store that this country was too small for a man to make a living in with a warden in it.

The first time, in January, he had paid two men from up the coast a hundred dollars to wait for Ez at the mouth of Oyster Bend. They waited two days, and when Ez came poling down on the third morning they stood up out of the mangroves with their rifles and could not do it. He put in to the bank and made coffee for the three of them, and they drank it, and went home, and told everybody.

The second time was this morning, and Duke had not hired anybody.

He'll try it again, said the older Whidden boy.

He will, said Lige. *Duke never quit a thing in his life once he started it.*

Retta had the splinter. She held it up to the lamp, a black wet spear of cypress as long as her finger joint, and laid it on the porch boards.

Ez came up the steps from the landing in his wet trousers with one shoe on, carrying the other.

What you all talking about?

They told him.

III. The Snare

The porch · later

Ez sat down on the top step and put his foot back in Retta's lap so she could wrap it, and looked out at the water a while.

That's not the first time, he said. *That's not the first time Duke's tried to kill me.*

The Whidden boys looked at each other, because they had not heard of any other time.

There was a buck deer, Ez said, *lived back in the pines, toward the Big Cypress, by a pond. And there was a Lord God bird in a dead cypress by the same pond, one of them big woodpeckers with the white on the wings, with her young ones. And there was an old snapping turtle that lived in the pond. They were friends, the three of them, the way things are that use the same water.*

A man came hunting through there and saw the buck's track at the drinking place, and he set a snare in it. Rawhide, plaited, strong as a trace chain. And that night the buck stepped in it and it took him by the leg and he hollered.

The Lord God bird came down, and the snapper came up out of the water. And the bird said, You've got the jaws. You chew that rope. I'll see to the man.

So the snapper went to chewing, and the bird flew off to the man's house and sat in a tree by the front door. And at daylight the man come out the front door with his knife, and that bird hit him in the face. Just hit him, wings and all. And he said, That's bad luck, and he went back in and lay down a while.

Then he thought, I'll go out the back. And the bird thought, He'll go out the back. And she went round and sat by the back door, and when he come out she hit him in the face again. So he went back in and lay down till the sun was all the way up, and then he went anyhow.

The bird flew back and hollered that he was coming. The snapper had chewed through all of it but one strand, and his mouth was all over blood, and

his jaws were about give out. And the buck saw the man coming through the pines, and he gave one jump and broke that last strand and went off in the palmettos. The bird went up to the top of her tree. But the snapper was so wore out he couldn't get back to the water. He just lay there. And the man picked him up and put him in a croker sack and hung it on a limb.

The buck saw that from the palmettos. And he come out where the man could see him, limping, like the snare had hurt his leg. And the man thought, I'll have him yet, and took after him. And the buck kept just out of reach, limping, way off into the scrub, a mile, two miles. Then he quit limping and went round another way fast as he could go, back to the pond, and he got that sack down with his horns and tore it open and turned the snapper out.

And he said to them, You saved my life. Now that man is coming back, and he'll take it out on you. You go in the water, he said to the snapper. And you take your young ones and go off somewhere else, he said to the bird. And they did. And the buck went back in the woods.

And the man come back, and there wasn't nothing at that pond but a torn sack. He picked it up and went home with it.

Retta had tied off the wrapping on his foot. Nobody said anything. Down under the house one of the children asked another one something in a whisper, and was hushed.

Who was the man? said the younger Whidden boy.

Same one as always, Ez said.

Lige laughed out loud, all at once, and then looked at Retta to see if he ought to have.

Then who's the snapper?

Well, said Ez, and looked at Lige, who had poled out to Chatham Bend after him in January with a shotgun across his knees, and had sat in the mangroves all night on the second night without telling anybody he was going, and had his hands still cut up from the oyster bars. And then he looked at Retta, who had walked in the dark to the store the night they took the Captain away and told Cal Roberts to his face what he was, with Duke standing right there, and had come home and gone to bed without saying one word about it.

I couldn't tell you, he said.

IV. The Fig

The landing · the next morning

In the morning he limped down to the landing to look at the skiff, and Lige and the older Whidden boy came down after him, because they had not got all they wanted out of the night before.

What are you going to do about him?

Ez did not answer that. He was standing under the gumbo limbo. He put his hand flat on the fig roots where they came down over the red bark, grey and smooth and thick as a man's arm, grown into each other at every place they crossed so that you could not tell where one let go and the next took hold. You could see the red of the limbo only in the gaps now, in little windows here and there, and the top of the old tree was mostly bare.

A bird eats a fig somewheres, he said, *and sits up in the top of a tree, and the seed comes out of him. And it sprouts up there in the crotch, in a little dirt, like nothing at all. And it lets a root down. Just a string. And the tree don't pay it any mind. Then it lets down another one, and another one, and they hit the ground, and they get thick, and they start in to holding hands.*

He knocked on one of the roots with his knuckle.

That limbo's been standing here since before the Indians quit this mound. In about five more years the fig'll have it choked to death, and it'll rot out inside, and there won't be anything there but the fig, standing up hollow where the tree used to be. You'll be able to see clear through it.

Lige said, *And that's you. And the fig is Duke.*

No, Ez said. *That limbo's Duke.*

He took his hand off the roots.

The fig is the thing in him, he said. *He let it down once, a long time ago, a little string of a thing, when we were boys. And he's been feeding it ever since. He thinks he's doing it to me.*

Then he said the verse, which his mother had said to him and Duke both, at the same table on Pine Island, when they were small and one of them had tried to get the other one in trouble.

> *Whoso diggeth a pit shall fall therein: and he that rolleth a stone, it will return upon him.*
>
> *— Proverbs 26:27*

And he went to bail the skiff.

V. The Trunk

Halfmoon Key · 1910 *to* 1916

That spring the State of New York passed a law against the plume trade, and New York was where the hats were made. Other states began to follow. By the fall the buyer in Key West would not answer Cal Roberts's letters. Cal took the cigar box off the counter, and after a while the brass scale. He came out to the warden's house one evening in 1911 and stood at the foot of the steps a long time without coming up, and then he set the scale on the bottom step and went home. Retta kept it, and weighed baking powder on it.

Duke had shot that whole spring, the spring of the splinter, harder than he had ever shot, and kept back the best of it to wait for the price. Nobody would trade with him on Halfmoon after the business at Plover Creek, and the young men who used to follow him found other things to do. He lived by himself after that on a key toward Lostmans, and fished a little, and came to the store less and less, and when he came he did not talk. He was forty-four years old and looked sixty. Ez sent him a mess of mullet by Lige every week or so, and every week or so Lige came back and said Duke had thrown it in the water.

When Duke died, in the winter of 1916, they found the trunk in his house, a sea chest with brass corners. It was full to the lid with plumes, six springs of them, packed in paper. The paper had gone brown and the plumes had gone the color of old teeth, and the mice had been in them, and they came apart when you lifted them. There was nobody left in the country to buy a single one. Ez and Lige carried the chest out of the house between them and stood a while, and then they burned it on the

shell beach below the house, plumes and all, because there was nothing else to do with them. The stink of it hung over the beach all afternoon.

By then the gumbo limbo at the landing had been dead three years. The children of Halfmoon used to play inside the fig. You could climb in at the bottom where two roots had not quite joined, and stand up in the hollow where the old tree had been, and look out through the windows in the lattice at the water and the boats and the mangroves, all around you, every way at once.

Background

The verse

> *He whose wickedness is very great brings himself down to that state where his enemy wishes him to be, as a creeper does with the tree which it surrounds.*
>
> Dhammapada 162, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the monks at Veḷuvana are talking about Devadatta, the Buddha's cousin and brother-in-law, who won the favor of Prince Ajātasattu, urged him to kill his father, King Bimbisāra (the Buddha's patron), and then plotted with him to kill the Buddha. The Buddha comes in and says this is not the first time, and tells the birth story of the antelope (Jātaka 206), in which the Bodhisatta is an antelope caught in a hunter's snare and saved by his friends the woodpecker and the tortoise; the hunter is Devadatta. He compares runaway wickedness to a māluvā creeper that wraps a sāla tree and crushes it. In other episodes of the same story, a splinter from a boulder Devadatta rolled down a hill wounded the Buddha's foot, and archers sent to kill him could not do it. Read the full commentary story, the antelope birth story, or about Devadatta.

Ten Thousand Islands, Florida

The Ten Thousand Islands, 1910

For thirty years, Florida's wading-bird rookeries were shot out for the millinery trade. Hunters killed egrets and herons at the nest in spring, when the breeding plumes were longest, and left the young to starve. Around 1904, according to the ornithologist Frank Chapman, plumes sold for $32 an ounce, more than the price of gold. Florida outlawed the killing of plume birds in 1901, and the American Ornithologists' Union, at the Florida Audubon Society's request, hired wardens to enforce it at $35 a month. In July 1905 the warden Guy Bradley was shot and killed near Flamingo while trying to stop a plume hunter, and in 1908 DeSoto County warden Columbus McLeod disappeared near Charlotte Harbor; his sunken boat was found but his body never was. In 1910 New York, the center of the hat trade, passed the Audubon Plumage Act, other states followed, and Congress soon banned the import of plumes. More on plume hunting.

Halfmoon Key and its people are invented. The Ten Thousand Islands are a maze of mangrove keys on Florida's southwest coast, and some of the higher ones are shell works raised by the region's Native peoples, where hammock trees like gumbo limbo grow. The Florida strangler fig usually sprouts from a bird-dropped seed in the crown of a host tree, sends roots down to the ground, and as the roots fuse around the trunk it usually kills the host and stands on its own. The state asylum at Chattahoochee, the Florida State Hospital for the Insane, opened in 1876.

After the story of Devadatta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 162). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

12.7

Porch Lights

But all things excellent are as difficult as they are rare.
— Spinoza, Ethics, tr. R. H. M. Elwes

Here is how I got it, at the dark end of Salvia Court.

I. The Round

Arvada, Colorado · Thursday, January 9, 1986

The club had observed on the Saturday nearest the new moon every month since 1969, and since November those Saturdays had belonged to the comet. By January Halley's was low in the southwest after supper, a smudge you could find in binoculars if somebody showed you where. In November sixty people had come out to the end of Salvia Court to be shown. In December it was three hundred, with cars parked down both sides of the street as far as the stop sign.

Gary Ochoa was the club's secretary. He was thirty-four, a letter carrier out of the Arvada post office, and he had been made secretary because he could tell you a week later what everyone had said. On Thursday he finished his route at three, kept his parka on, and started up Salvia Court with a clipboard.

There were fourteen houses on the court. Mrs. Vogel's was the last on the west side, where the pavement ended at a wire fence and the grass ran on toward the foothills. That was the direction the comet was in, and it was the only dark direction there was. The Astronomical League had been after every town in the country for a year to turn its lights down on the good nights. It called the campaign Dark Skies for Comet Halley. Gary's part of the campaign was fourteen doorbells.

He asked the same thing at each one. Would they mind leaving the porch light off on Saturday, and the garage floods, from half past five until eight? The Akerses said sure. The widow in the split-level said she would if he would come and tell her when it was safe to turn it on again. A man named Dufresne, who had the big yard light on a pole, said he paid Public Service for that light and he would think about it. The ninth house had been empty and for sale since August, and the realtor left its porch light burning day and night. Gary wrote her number down off the sign.

He was coming down the walk of the eleventh house when Del Rainey's Suburban pulled to the curb beside him.

Del owned three muffler shops and had the best eye in the club. He could star-hop to a twelfth-magnitude galaxy without a chart while other men were still leveling their tripods. In the back of the Suburban, with the seats folded down, lay seventeen and a half inches of mirror in a red cardboard tube the size of a water heater.

Gary. Tell Ruth something for me. He did not turn off the engine. *Starting this new moon, I'm holding my own observing. Apart from Ruth, and apart from the club. Meetings too. I've got bylaws typed.*

He had leased forty acres out past Deer Trail, seventy miles east, where there was no light from one edge of the sky to the other. He had five rules, and he gave them to Gary through the window. The dark site only. Members only, and no public nights. Nobody under sixteen. No instrument under ten inches. And you came at dusk and stayed until dawn, because he was not going to have headlights at midnight.

Three hundred people, Gary. Breathing on my eyepieces, asking me is that it. I've got five men who can find things for themselves. That's a club.

Then he drove out of the court. Gary did the last three houses, because he had said he would.

II. The Garage

Mrs. Vogel's · the same evening

Ruth Vogel was sixty-three. During the war the Army had run short of roof prisms for its gunsights, and eighty amateur telescope makers around the country had made them in cellars and garages, twenty-eight thousand prisms in all. Her father, in Dayton, was one of the eighty, and from the time she was nineteen Ruth had done his fine grinding. Afterward she ground eyeglass lenses for a wholesale house on Larimer Street until her eyes were sixty. On Tuesday and Thursday nights she taught mirror making in her garage to anyone who came. There were four oil drums filled with sand to work on, and a tester at the back made from a coffee can, a flashlight bulb and a razor blade.

She was at the tester when Gary came in. A boy named Kevin, who was thirteen, was at the near drum pushing a six-inch disk of glass back and forth across another one.

Gary told it the way he would have read back the minutes.

Mrs. Vogel. This afternoon, after my route, I took the clipboard and went up the court to ask about the lights. And while I was going up the court asking about the lights, Del Rainey saw me. He pulled over to where I was, and he said this to me: Starting this new moon, I'm holding my own observing, apart from Ruth and apart from the club. Meetings too. He stopped. *He means it. Saturday he's going to split the club in two.*

She kept her eye at the razor blade until she had finished what she was looking at. Then she switched off the little bulb.

That was easy for him, she said. *You couldn't have done it. You'd have been a week getting your mouth open. And what you did today, the fourteen doorbells, Del couldn't do if you held a gun on him. People say doing right is hard and doing wrong is easy. It depends a good deal on who's doing it.*

Kevin had stopped to listen. She went over and looked at his glass under the lamp.

You're through with the two-twenty. Before you open the three-twenty you wash everything. The glass, the tool, the drum, your apron. Your fingernails.

One grain of the coarse on the fine and you've put a scratch across forty hours. You don't have to be careless to do it. You just have to not be careful, once.

She nodded at the long white tube standing in the corner, the six-inch the club kept for anybody at a public night who had come without a telescope.

Del made the mirror in that. Nineteen seventy-one, on that drum you're at. He had it polished out, and there was one grain of the one-twenty in his shirt cuff. I made him finish it anyway. You can't see the scratch at the eyepiece. It throws a little light around, that's all. He never could look through it afterward. He gave it to the club the day his next one came back from the coater.

Kevin went to the laundry tub with the nail brush. Over the tub, where everyone who ground glass in that garage sooner or later stood scrubbing, was an index card gone brown, typed on her father's machine in 1942. He had told her that the man who wrote it ground lenses for his living in a rented room, and that the dust had helped to kill him. Kevin read it with the water running, as they all did.

> *If the way which I have pointed out as leading to this result seems exceedingly hard, it may nevertheless be discovered. Needs must it be hard, since it is so seldom found. How would it be possible, if salvation were ready to our hand, and could without great labour be found, that it should be by almost all men neglected? But all things excellent are as difficult as they are rare.*
>
> *— Spinoza, Ethics, Part V, Prop. XLII, note, tr. R. H. M. Elwes*

What do I tell him? Gary said.

Tell him Saturday is at half past five, the same as it would have been. She turned the little bulb back on. *And call that realtor.*

III. The New Moon

Salvia Court · Saturday, January 11

At a quarter past five Gary walked the court once more, without the clipboard. The sun was behind the mountains and the cars had begun to come.

The Akerses' light went off while he was still on their walk. The widow's went off when he rang. At the house for sale he stood on Mr. Akers's stepladder and backed the porch bulb out two turns, as the realtor had said he might. Up and down the court the windows went dim one after another as people pulled their drapes. By half past five there were thirteen dark porches and Dufresne's yard light, blue-white on its pole, laying the shadow of his spruce the whole way across the street.

The telescopes stood in a row along the wire fence with their backs to it. There were two hundred people by six and more behind them. The bright thing low in the southwest was Jupiter, and half the line took it for the comet and had to be told. Mrs. Vogel ran the six-inch with the scratched mirror, because it was the one the children could reach.

At twenty to six the yard light went out. Nobody had gone to the door again. Gary saw Dufresne come down his driveway in a car coat and get on the end of the line.

A girl of nine or so got up on the step stool and put her eye where she was shown. She was quiet for some time.

Is that it?

That's it, Mrs. Vogel said.

It looks like somebody breathed on the glass.

It does. It's more than a hundred million miles from here tonight. It comes back in 2061. How old will you be?

The girl worked it out on the stool with her mittens off. *Eighty-four.*

Then look a little longer, Mrs. Vogel said, and the line waited.

Out past Deer Trail it was eleven degrees and black down to the ground. Del Rainey had the better sky that night, and nobody on Salvia Court ever said otherwise. In seventeen and a half inches the comet had a tail. There were five men there to see it, and they had each seen it by sev-

en. In the spring two of them came back to the garage, and found their drums where they had left them.

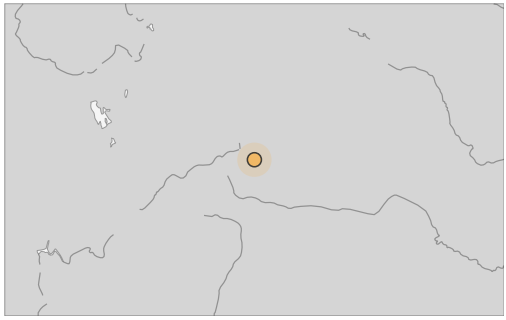
At ten to eight the comet went down behind the foothills. Mrs. Vogel put the cap on the six-inch. Gary stood at the fence and watched the court. For a minute it stayed as it was. Then Dufresne's light came on, and the widow's, and after that the rest, up one side and down the other, as each house got home and decided.

Background

The verse

> *Bad deeds, and deeds hurtful to ourselves, are easy to do; what is beneficial and good, that is very difficult to do.*
>
> Dhammapada 163, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is a single paragraph. Devadatta, the Buddha's cousin, has made up his mind to break the community in two. He meets the elder Ānanda on his morning round for alms and tells him that from that day he will keep the observance day, the gathering held at each new and full moon, and carry on the community's business apart from the Buddha and apart from the monks. Ānanda goes back and repeats it word for word. The Buddha answers with a solemn utterance, that good is easy for the good and hard for the bad, and bad is easy for the bad and hard for the noble, and then with the verse. In the older account in the monastic code, Devadatta's occasion for leaving was a list of five stricter rules that he wanted laid on everyone. Read the full commentary story. The series tells other parts of his story in Strangler Fig and The Partition.



Arvada, Colorado

Arvada, 1986

The 1986 return of Halley's Comet was the least favorable on record, with the comet on the far side of the sun from the earth at its brightest. For the northern states the best evening views came in the first half of January, before it sank into the twilight ahead of its passage round the sun on February 9: a dim patch low in the southwest, best found with binoculars, on the moonless nights around the new moon of January 10. Light pollution kept many people from seeing it at all. The Astronomical League, the federation of American amateur clubs, ran a campaign it called Dark Skies for Comet Halley, asking towns to dim their outdoor lights on the best nights. The comet is due back in July 2061. Arvada is a suburb on the northwest side of Denver. The club, the court and everyone on it are invented.

Grinding a telescope mirror by hand, glass on glass over a weighted drum with finer and finer grit, has been a hobby in America since the 1920s, and the knife-edge test can be made with a small lamp and a razor blade. A single coarse grain carried over into a finer stage will scratch the work. During the Second World War Albert Ingalls of *Scientific American* organized amateur mirror makers to supply roof prisms for military instruments; about eighty of them made more than twenty-eight thousand. Spinoza earned his living grinding lenses. The words on the card are the last lines of his *Ethics*, in R. H. M. Elwes's translation of 1883.

After the story of Devadatta's attempt to split the Saṅgha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 163). The original. Words from Spinoza's *Ethics*, tr. R. H. M. Elwes (1883). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

12.8

The Nooning

> *…this language, as simple as nature, is capable of extending itself like her, and of attaining the furthest limits of human thought.*
> *— Laurent Clerc, Address at the Connecticut Asylum, Hartford, 28 May 1818*

Thus it was signed to me, on Meetinghouse Hill.

I. Cow

Meetinghouse Hill, Tolland County · winter 1810

I AM THE HALE BOY. KEEP THAT IN FRONT OF YOU WHILE I TELL this. I was not born yet when this first part happened, and when the rest of it happened I was nine years old and had no words, not one. I had pointing, and I had my mother's face. What I tell you I put together afterward, out of what I saw, and what was written down, and what Mrs. Kingsbury wrote out for me when we were both old. Watch my hands. I will go slowly.

Thankful Root. Her house stood at the south corner of the green, so near the meetinghouse that on a still Sabbath the minister came in at her kitchen window, and she was the one person in the kitchen who did not know it. A fever took her hearing in her second year. In 1810 she was forty-four. She kept the books of her husband's hat shop in figures she had worked out for herself, could cut a coat by eye and dress a hog, and on the Sabbath she sat on the short bench under the pulpit, where the town put the hard of hearing, between two old soldiers holding their tin trumpets up at the preacher, and watched his mouth for three hours and got nothing out of it.

She and Ezra had made a language between them, the way two people will who have to. A sign for flour. A sign for the red cow. One for the minister, the chin lifted. One for each of their boys, and later one for each of the boys' graves. Their girl Huldah had all of it from the cradle. The rest of the town had pointing and nodding, and an opinion, which the minister shared, that Mrs. Root understood about what the red cow understood and was to be pitied for it on fast days.

That winter the district hired Asa Pember to keep the school, a young man out of Windham County with two years of Yale College in him and no money to finish. Schoolmasters boarded round then, a week at each house for each scholar sent, and when his weeks came to the Roots' he was the first person in her life who thought of writing. He brought a slate home from the schoolhouse. He drew a cow on it and wrote under the cow.

COW

She looked at it a long time. Then she took the pencil out of his hand and drew a line from the cow to the word, hard, so that the slate squealed, as if she were tying a rope.

He told people afterward he had never seen anybody so hungry. He meant it kindly. He meant most things kindly.

By spring she could read a hundred names of things. When his weeks were up he did not move on. He took the chamber over the hat shop and paid what he could, which was little. When Ezra died two winters later it was Asa Pember who wrote out on the slate what the doctor had said, and what the minister said at the grave, and who sat with her in the kitchen afterward while she made the sign for Ezra on the table with one finger, over and over. He did not know that sign. She did not teach it to him.

II. Mullein

The widow's kitchen, at the nooning · 1812–1818

Six years. She kept his shirts and knit his stockings and set his plate at her table where she had set her sons', and he was a son to her, near enough, and he knew it, and it was the best thing he had.

On the Sabbath he took notes of the morning sermon in a little book on his knee. At the nooning, while the farm families went down to the noon-houses on the lower side of the green to thaw out and fill their foot stoves, he crossed to her kitchen and ate her cold beans and brown bread and wrote the sermon out for her. The text, the doctrine, the heads. He chose the words she had.

FIRSTLY. SIN.
SECONDLY. GOD SEES.
THIRDLY. OBEY. GIVE.

She read them and nodded. He wiped the slate with the side of his hand, and they went back up the hill for the afternoon. That was her whole religion for six years: three or four words a week and a hand wiped across them. She thought it was a short religion and a hard one, and that it was all there was of it for a woman like her. He thought so too. That is the thing to understand about him. He was not lying to her.

One October he taught her the weed by the pasture wall. He drew it two ways. The first year, the flat grey rosette lying on the ground, leaves soft as flannel. The second year, the tall stalk with the yellow flowers going up it like a candle. Through the second picture he drew a line.

MULLEIN

She had known that all her life. Every farm woman knows the mullein blooms once and then stands dead all winter on its own stalk. What she had not known was that it could be written and kept. On dark evenings

he cut the dry stalks along the wall and dipped them in her tallow pot and walked out to the schoolhouse with one burning in his hand, and she watched the little fire go along the road from her window and knew the word for it.

• • •

The Kingsburys had the farm two miles out on the Bolton road. In the cold year, when there was frost in June and half the hill sold up and went to Ohio, the Kingsburys stayed. Their third child, Lydia, was born deaf. In the fall of 1817 Eli Kingsbury sold his young oxen and borrowed on his woodlot and drove her twenty miles to Hartford, to the Asylum that had opened that spring in the old City Hotel, and paid a hundred dollars for six months. In April he found the second hundred; nobody knew how. In October of 1818 he could not find the third. He drove to Hartford and brought her home to wait.

She came home talking.

I saw it, the first Sabbath. My mother had heard something and took me down to the Kingsbury noon-house at the nooning: a low shed, a stone chimney at one end, the horses at the other, smoke and wet wool and horse. There was Lydia on the bench by the fire, fifteen years old. There was old Abner Fuller from the east parish, who was born deaf and drove oxen and had never in sixty-one years said a thing to anybody that he could not point at. And her hands were going. Fast as a fiddler's, her face going with them. She spelled on her fingers. She wrote whole lines on a slate. She made a shape in the air with both hands, and Abner Fuller wept, an old man with ice in his beard, in front of everybody, and my mother put her hand over her own mouth. I stood there with my nothing. I did not know yet I was looking at words. I only knew I was hungry. That is the right word. Pember was right about that word.

Mrs. Peck, who lived next door to the widow, was in the shed too. She went home and stood in the widow's kitchen and said it to Huldah, and Huldah turned it into the household signs. Huldah wrote it down for me afterward. Huldah kept everything.

She talks, Thankful. With her hands. About the Almighty, and the stars, and the soul, and old Fuller understood every bit of it. I never saw the like of it in my life. You ought to go and see.

III. No

The same week · October 1818

Monday at supper the widow made the sign for Lydia Kingsbury, a hand drawing down a braid, which she had used since the girl was in long clothes. Then two fingers out from her own eyes, toward the Bolton road. I want to see.

He took the slate off its nail.

> NO. THEY ARE FRENCH SIGNS.
> YOU WOULD NOT FOLLOW.

Wednesday, at the woodpile, she asked again. He wrote with the slate against his knee.

> YOU ARE TOO OLD TO BE-GIN.
> IT WILL MUDDLE WHAT YOU HAVE.

Friday, at the well, the third time. He wrote, and did not look at her while she read it.

> THE TOWN WILL LAUGH AT YOU.

Why? He told himself it was for her. Here is what was under that, where a man keeps what he does not look at. If the Kingsbury girl could talk to her, the slate would go back to the schoolhouse. His plate would be a plate on the table, and he would be a boarder. For eight years he had been the only door into that house, and he could not think what he would be if there were another.

I know this because he wrote it, the next year, in a letter to Huldah from Ohio. I told you she kept everything.

The widow read each slate and nodded, and he wiped it, and he thought that was the end of it.

IV. Tree, Green

The Kingsbury noon-house · the first Sabbath in November 1818

Frost on everything. She ate her breakfast by candle and filled her foot stove from the hearth. Before they went out she put her hand on Huldah's cheek, and pointed at the bean pot, and the bread, and Pember's chair. Feed him. Huldah nodded.

That morning the minister preached on the new constitution, voted in by a hair in October, which ended the Standing Order and, by his account, very possibly the world. Pember wrote it in his book. At the blessing the widow went out the door with her foot stove and turned away from home, across the green and down the hill toward the noon-houses.

He went to the kitchen. Huldah set out the beans and the bread and a mug of cider. Huldah wrote down for me what was said. I have it here.

Where is your mother?

At the Kingsburys' noon-house, sir. She has gone to see Lyddy.

He put the spoon down. Huldah said his face went the color of the coals in the stove. He said out loud, to no one, *So. She has done with me,* and went out across the green without his hat.

• • •

Now I was there. This part is mine.

She came in out of the cold and sat at the end of the bench with the foot stove under her skirts, and Lydia looked at her a long time. Lydia did not begin with Hartford. She began with the widow. She made a little asking face and opened her hands: show me yours. And the widow, slowly, the way you take things out of a chest that has been shut for years, showed her. Flour. The red cow. The minister. Ezra. Lydia gave each one back to her, and some of them Lydia's hands had already, because the signs at Hartford were made the same way, out of how a thing looks and how it moves. Mr. Clerc's rule, which he had from the Abbé Sicard, was that you go from the known to the unknown. Lydia had it from him, and I have it from her.

Then she took a burnt stick out of the fire and wrote on the hearthstone.

TREE GREEN

She pointed out the door at the hemlock by the horse shed. Tree. Green. She drew a line between the two words, the way the widow had once drawn a line from a cow to its name. Then she rubbed the line out with her thumb and wrote in its place:

IS

The widow looked at that a long time. I looked at it too, though I could not read, because everybody was looking at it.

Then Lydia lifted her own hand, slowly, and let it fall. Lifted it again. She pointed at the hand: this? And shook her head. She touched her arm: this? No. She touched her forehead, and then her breast, and then she made a sign none of us had ever seen, both hands opening out from the breast the way shutters open on a shop in the morning. And she pointed at the widow.

That is when the door let the cold in, and Asa Pember stood in it with no hat.

I did not hear what he said. Nobody in that shed heard it but the Kingsburys and Mrs. Peck and my mother. Mrs. Kingsbury wrote it out for me fifty years later in a good round hand. This is what his mouth said.

Mrs. Kingsbury, I beg you, let her be. She cannot follow this. I have taught her eight years and I know her measure. If the girl must teach her something, let it be the Commandments, and to put her penny in the box. That much she can hold.

And he made at the widow the household sign for *come home*, which was Ezra's.

Lydia watched his mouth. She could not read mouths well, but she read faces the way a pilot reads water. She wiped her slate on her skirt and wrote and held it up to him.

YOU ARE AFRAID
SHE WILL NOT WANT YOU.

Then she took out of her apron a thin printed pamphlet. It was the address Mr. Clerc had written for the examination in May, which Mr. Gallaudet read aloud for him before the Governor and both houses, while the forty-two of them sat in rows and watched the words go over their heads into the hearing people. She had carried it home with her. She opened it and set her finger under a line and held it up, and he read it. He could not help it. He was a man who read whatever was put in front of him.

> *Every creature, every work of God, is admirably well made; but if any one appears imperfect in our eyes, it does not belong to us to criticise it. Perhaps, that which we do not find right in its kind, turns to our advantage, without our being able to perceive it.*
>
> *— Laurent Clerc, Address at the Connecticut Asylum, Hartford, 28 May 1818*

Then one more line on the slate, her own.

IT IS YOURSELF YOU HURT.

Mrs. Peck said afterward he looked like a man who has walked into a post in the dark.

And the widow did not look at him. That is what I remember best. He had been the door of her house for eight years and she did not turn her head. She was looking at the hearthstone. She lifted her hand. She let it fall. She lifted it again and turned it over and looked at the back of it, and then at Lydia's hand, and at old Fuller's, big and broken on his knees, and at mine, and at Asa Pember's hanging at his side, and I saw it go into her. I have no better way to put it. Whatever lifted the hand was not in the hand. It was in hers, and in all of ours, and in his too, standing there in the door. It had been in her the whole of her life on the short bench under the pulpit, and nobody had come in to it, and it had not waited on anybody to come.

She made the sign Lydia had made. Both hands, opening from the breast.

Lydia's face did something I have no sign for.

Old Fuller made it. My mother made it, crying, badly, the way hearing people make signs. And I made it, and it was my first word, and I made it three times over because I could not believe I had one, and Lydia laughed and caught my hands and made me do it slower.

The bell went for afternoon meeting. Asa Pember went out first.

V. The Wall

The Bolton road · March 1819

In December the widow sold Ezra's hat blocks and his bow and the last of the felt to a hatter in Coventry, and walked out the Bolton road with the money tied in a stocking, and put it on Eli Kingsbury's table. Nobody had taught her the duty of almsgiving. In January Lydia went back to Hartford.

After that, at the nooning, the widow went down to the noon-house, and old Fuller and I and two more who had heard of it and walked over from the next town sat by the fire with her, and she gave us what she had. Flour. Cow. Tree. Green. Is. She was a slow teacher. She had a great deal of time for it.

Asa Pember kept the school to the end of the term. He still ate at her table; she still set his plate; there was nothing in her that wanted to punish him. But he did not take the slate off the nail again, and she did not hand it to him. In March he went west with the Pecks, who had the Ohio fever like half the hill.

I saw him go. It was very early. The wagon went out past the pasture wall, where last summer's mullein stood along the stones in a row, grey and dry, every stalk gone to seed and dead on its feet since September, and he did not look at them. He was looking back at the corner of the green, where she stood in her doorway with the slate in her two hands. She had wiped it clean. She held it up toward the wagon so he could see there was nothing on it, and she held it there until the wagon was over the hill.

Background

The verse

> *The foolish man who scorns the rule of the venerable (Arahat), of the elect (Ariya), of the virtuous, and follows false doctrine, he bears fruit to his own destruction, like the fruits of the Katthaka reed.*
>
> Dhammapada 164, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a laywoman of Sāvatthī looks after the Elder Kāla "with the tenderness of a mother for a son." When her neighbors come home praising the Buddha's teaching, she asks to hear it too, and three days running Kāla talks her out of it, thinking that once she has heard the Teacher she will have no more use for him. On an Observance Day she goes anyway, telling her daughter to feed the elder. When he learns where she is, he hurries to the monastery in a jealous rage and tells the Buddha the woman is too stupid for subtle teaching and should be taught only giving and the precepts. The Buddha sees his motive, tells him he strives only to his own hurt, and speaks the verse of the reed that dies when it bears fruit. The woman

attains stream-entry, and the others listening benefit too. There is no past-life story. Read the full commentary story.

Meetinghouse Hill (fictional), Tolland County, Connecticut

Hartford and the hill towns, 1817–1819

The Connecticut Asylum for the Education and Instruction of Deaf and Dumb Persons opened in Hartford on April 15, 1817, in the old Bennet's City Hotel, with Thomas Hopkins Gallaudet and the French Deaf teacher Laurent Clerc, a former pupil of the Abbé Sicard's school in Paris. The committee's first report lists parents' advances of a hundred dollars for six months and regrets that its means were "altogether inadequate to the support and instruction of those pupils who are in indigent Circumstances." Two of the first pupils came from Hebron, in Tolland County. At a public examination on May 28, 1818, before the governor and both houses of the legislature, Gallaudet read aloud an address Clerc had written. It describes Sicard's method of following "the uninterrupted line from the known to the unknown" and counts forty-two deaf pupils in the room. In the winter of 1818–19 it became the first school of primary and secondary education to receive federal aid. Pupils brought home signs and village sign languages to Hartford, where they mixed with Clerc's French signs, and American Sign Language emerged at the school.

On October 5, 1818, Connecticut voters ratified the state's first written constitution by a narrow margin, 13,918 votes, just under 53 percent of those cast. It ended the established church, the "Standing Order" that the Toleration Party had campaigned against (more at Today in Connecticut History). Meetinghouses were unheated, and between the morning and afternoon services many Connecticut congregations ate and refilled their foot stoves in "noon-houses" or "Sabba-day houses," low sheds with a chimney at one end; many meetinghouses also kept a seat near the pulpit for the hard of hearing (Alice Morse Earle, *The Sabbath in Puritan New England*). Two years earlier, in the year without a summer, frost in June and a ruined corn crop had sent many Connecticut families west in the "Ohio fever."

After the story of the Elder Kāla from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 164). The original. Scripture, here, from Laurent Clerc's *Address* (Hartford: Hudson and Co., 1818). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

12.9

Windmill Water

> *According to the cleanness of my hands hath he recompensed me.*
> *— Psalm 18:20*

Now the way I got it, on the south road out of Borger.

I. The Tent

Borger, Hutchinson County, Texas · a Saturday night in September 1926

The town was six months old and had forty-five thousand people in it. Most of them lived in tents and tar-paper shacks along a Main Street three miles long, and the water came from somewhere else, in tank wagons, and was sold off the tailgate.

Calvin Odom was twenty-four, off a cotton farm in Wise County, and he worked in the hot houses at the carbon plant south of town. The plant burned gas against iron in long sheet-metal sheds and scraped off what the flame left. What it left was the blackest stuff there is, finer than flour. It went into automobile tires, and into Calvin. He came off shift black to the roots of his hair and coughed black in the mornings. There had been two Odoms at the plant when he hired on, no kin to each other, so the bigger man was Big Black and Calvin was Little Black. Then in July a crew looking for a stolen truck had caught Big Black on the south road at night, alone, and by the time anyone learned he'd had no part in it he was dead.

Little Black had gone forward at the Salvation Army's open-air on Main Street in June. He could not have said why that night. A woman of fifty in a blue bonnet had been playing a concertina in front of a domino

hall with her eyes shut, and he had been walking past with his pay in his shoe.

She was Ensign Cora Beale. She had worked the oil towns since Ranger, and she had come up from Amarillo with a lieutenant, a drum, and a brown tent that she pitched on a lot behind the lumber yard. Calvin was not sworn in yet. He was what the Army called a recruit. He washed as well as a man could wash in two quarts of bought water and sat on the second bench.

That Saturday the Ensign held an All Night of Prayer, nine o'clock to daylight. About twenty people stayed for it. There was singing, then testimony, then singing again. Twice in the night she stood up and talked for most of an hour, plainly and quietly, about what a man does and what is done to him and which of the two he will have to carry. Calvin heard all of it. He did not once leave the bench. People remembered that afterward because the bench was short and they had to climb over him.

II. The Road

The south road · Sunday, first light

He came out of the tent when the east was the color of dishwater and started for the plant camp.

A quarter mile past the last shacks the road ran by a ranch windmill. It had been there before the town, an Aermotor on a thirty-foot steel tower with a round stock tank at its foot, and the rancher had not got around to fencing it off from forty-five thousand strangers. Calvin had the windmill in sight when a Ford touring car came up the road behind him with its lamps off. It went by close enough to fan his trouser legs. Something came out of the back seat, hit the caliche in front of him and slid.

It was a canvas bank sack, tied at the neck. The Ford was already over the rise.

He was standing over the sack, working out whose it might be, when the truck came. There were five men on it, a drilling crew, and their driller was a man named Hoyt Larrabee whose payroll had walked out of a contractor's shack at gunpoint an hour before. They saw a man alone on

the south road at daybreak, black to the eyes, with their sack between his feet.

There he is, Larrabee said. *Sat in the Army tent all night so he'd have it to tell, and went hijacking by morning.*

Calvin said he had been at prayer. It was the wrong thing to say, because it was what Larrabee had just said he would say. They took him off his feet. They used their fists and their boots, and one of them used a doubled length of sash cord across his back and neck. He got his arms over his head and kept them there. He did not hit anybody. Between blows he could hear the windmill, which needed grease, and through it one of the men saying they ought to do the thing right this time. He heard that man walk back to the truck and take a coil of rope from under the seat.

He understood that this was how it had gone for Big Black.

III. The Tank

The windmill · sunup

FIVE WOMEN WERE COMING OUT ALONG THE ROAD FROM town.

They were from Dixon Street. Anybody would have known it, at that hour, by the kimonos under their coats. Each had a towel over her shoulder and one carried a cake of soap in a saucer. The windmill tank was the only water in Borger that nobody charged for, and daybreak on a Sunday was the only hour of the week when there were neither cattle at it nor men. They came out every Sunday. They had passed the brown tent on the way, as they had passed it going the other direction at midnight.

The one in front was Opal Sykes. She was thirty-five and had been in Ranger and Burkburnett, the same as the Ensign, in a different line of work. She paid the city eighteen dollars every week for the privilege, which was more than could be said for Hoyt Larrabee.

You boys go on about your business, she said. *This man didn't do any such thing.*

Larrabee kept his knee where it was. *What would you know about it?*

I know that tent's been singing since nine last night. I went by it at twelve and I went by it at three with a sick headache, and he was on the second bench both times with his mouth open. I know that Ford. I know who was in it. He paid Jimmie out of a roll at two o'clock and told her where the next roll was coming from, and it was your shack, Hoyt. And I know every one of you by your Christian name and what you owe.

Nobody on the truck found anything to say to that. The man with the rope looked at it and put it back under the seat. Larrabee stood up. He picked the sack off the road, hefted it, and found it was all there. He got on the truck with his crew and they went back toward town a good deal slower than they had come.

Calvin sat up in the road. His nose was broken. One eye was shutting.

The women helped him as far as the tank and sat him on the rim. The youngest, the one called Jimmie, wet a corner of her towel and reached for his face. Opal took her wrist.

Let him. He has two hands. She set the saucer on the rim beside him. *Wash your own face, Little Black. Then go on, so we can have our bath.*

He washed. The blood came off, and under the blood some of the black, and the water he had dirtied went out over the lip of the tank into the mud. The wheel turned overhead and brought up more through the lead pipe, a pulse at a time, clear.

IV. The Bench

The tent · Sunday morning

He walked back the way he had come. The soldiers were setting the benches straight for knee-drill, and they stopped when they saw him.

Some men about killed me on the south road, he said. *They took me for a hijacker. Some women from Dixon Street got me off. I'd be dead, only for them.*

They sat him down and went for the Ensign, and told it to her as he had told it. One of them, a carpenter named Tuttle who had been saved eleven years, said it was a hard thing for a praying man to owe his life to that kind of woman, and a harder thing for the Army to have it said.

Ensign Beale looked at Calvin's face a while. She had her Bible, and she did not need to open it.

Brother Odom is alive this morning because those women spoke up, and because he hadn't done it. It took both. They could not have talked him free if he had been guilty, and he could not have talked himself free at all.

> *The soul that sinneth, it shall die. The son shall not bear the iniquity of the father, neither shall the father bear the iniquity of the son: the righteousness of the righteous shall be upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked shall be upon him.*
>
> *— Ezekiel 18:20*

What a man does is on him, she said. *What he leaves undone is on him too, and it comes off the same way. I have been twenty years in the Army, Brother Tuttle. I never yet washed anybody. I never saw it done.*

Then she sent the lieutenant for iodine.

• • •

That evening the Army held its open-air on Dixon Street, as it did every Sunday, with the drum and the concertina. Opal Sykes sat on her step in a clean shirtwaist with her hair still damp and did not come forward. Nobody had expected she would.

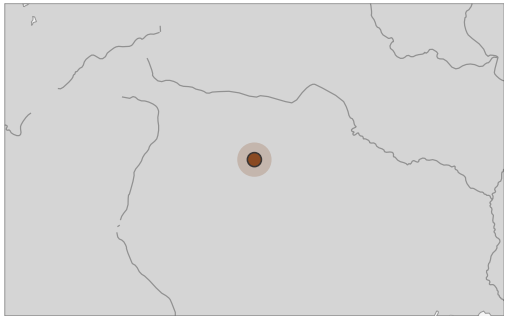
Calvin Odom was not in the ring. He had walked out the south road in the afternoon with two buckets and walked back in with them full, a mile and a quarter, with one eye shut. When the singing started he crossed the street and set one bucket on her step. On the rim of it he had balanced her saucer, with a new cake of soap.

Background

The verse

> *By oneself the evil is done, by oneself one suffers; by oneself evil is left undone, by oneself one is purified. Purity and impurity belong to oneself, no one can purify another.*
>
> Dhammapada 165, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the lay disciple Culla Kāḷa ("Little Black") spends a whole night at the monastery listening to the teaching. As he walks home at dawn, thieves running from the people they have robbed throw their loot down in front of him. The pursuers seize him, say he played the thief by night and only pretended to be listening to the Dhamma, and beat him. Some courtesans on their way to the river bathing place tell the men he did nothing of the sort and get him released. When the monks report it, the Buddha says he was saved both by the women's intercession and by his own innocence, and speaks the verse. The story opens by pointing back to an earlier one, in which a layman named Mahā Kāḷa ("Big Black"), caught the same way, was beaten to death. Read the full commentary story.



Borger, Texas

Borger, *1926*

Borger was laid out in March 1926 after oil was struck in the Texas Panhandle, and within ninety days some 45,000 people had come to it. The Handbook of Texas records a Main Street three miles long, drinking water delivered in tank wagons until wells were drilled, and a town government run by a crime syndicate. Dixon Street was the vice district; by one account its women each paid the city marshals a weekly "fine" of eighteen dollars. Armed robbers were called hijackers. Federal agents and Texas Rangers raided the town in October 1926, the Rangers returned in force the next spring, and in 1929 the governor put Borger under martial law. Thomas Hart Benton painted it as *Boomtown*.

The first carbon black plant in the Panhandle was authorized in Hutchinson County in March 1926. The channel process burned natural gas against iron and collected the soot for tire rubber, and within a decade the plants around Borger were darkening the town's dust storms. The Salvation Army's members are soldiers and its clergy hold military ranks; ensign was one of them in the 1920s. Its all-night prayer meetings, outdoor services with drum and concertina, and early Sunday "knee-drill" all date from its first decades. The Army's tent in Borger is invented, as are Calvin Odom, Ensign Beale, Opal Sykes and the rest, and the killing of the man called Big Black.

After the story of the lay disciple Culla Kāḷa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 165). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

12.10

Spiritual Bouquet

love ought to be put more in deeds than in words.
— Spiritual Exercises, Contemplation to Gain Love

The way I heard it, in the back booths at the Bevo Mill.

I. The Last Conference

The White House, St. Louis County · March 1949

Every year in the third week of Lent, Norbert Vogt packed a shaving kit and two clean shirts and drove down the river road with the men of his parish to the White House, where the Jesuits had been giving retreats to laymen since 1922. It stood on the bluffs south of the city, eighty acres of oaks and lawn above the Mississippi. For three days nobody spoke. When the bell rang the men went to the chapel and sat in rows in their good suits and listened to Father Brockmeier.

He had given the White House retreats for twenty-four years. He was a big, slow German from Hermann, on the Missouri, with a farmer's hands and a voice that did not rise, and the men who came back every year could have given his conferences for him. Thursday night, what a man is made for. Friday, death and judgment. Saturday, the two standards, Christ's and the other one. Sunday, love. They called him Father Brock. They had brought their sons to him, and he had married the sons.

Norbert was forty-six. He was regional sales manager for Ralston Purina in southeast Missouri and southern Illinois, the Bootheel and Little Egypt: eleven salesmen and two hundred and some dealers. He spent four nights a week in hotels in Sikeston and Cape Girardeau, talking Pig Chow with men in overalls under red-and-white checkerboard signs. Over the desks at Checkerboard Square hung the four squares Mr. Dan-

forth had drawn for his salesmen, physical, mental, social and religious, a man's life in balance. Norbert had made fifteen retreats. He went home from every one of them a cleaner man, the way a man is cleaner after a haircut, and it lasted about as long.

On the Sunday afternoon, at the last conference, Father Brock did what he did every year. He opened the little black book he had carried since his novitiate and read them the page he had read on Thursday night, so they would take it home with them.

> *Man is created to praise, reverence, and serve God our Lord, and by this means to save his soul. And the other things on the face of the earth are created for man and that they may help him in prosecuting the end for which he is created. From this it follows that man is to use them as much as they help him on to his end, and ought to rid himself of them so far as they hinder him as to it. For this it is necessary to make ourselves indifferent to all created things in all that is allowed to the choice of our free will and is not prohibited to it; so that, on our part, we want not health rather than sickness, riches rather than poverty, honor rather than dishonor, long rather than short life, and so in all the rest; desiring and choosing only what is most conducive for us to the end for which we are created.*
>
> *— Spiritual Exercises, Principle and Foundation*

Then he closed the book and took off his glasses.

The doctors at Desloge tell me I will be here until about the Fourth of July, he said. *That is four months, if you are counting, and you will be. I wanted you to hear it from me and not from the Sisters. Now go home to your wives.*

He gave them the blessing and went out by the sacristy door.

For a while nobody moved. When the bell rang the end of silence, seventy men came out onto the lawn and stood in knots along the bluff with their hats in their hands. Al Huelsmann, who had a plumbing business on Gravois and had been head captain for the parish men since before the war, went from knot to knot, and in every one somebody asked him the same thing. *Al, what are we going to do?* Al said they would do something. He did not know yet what.

Norbert stood by himself at the rail. Below him a towboat was pushing nine barges up the river against the spring water, so slowly that it hardly seemed to move.

He was thinking about his first retreat, in 1934, when half his dealers were carrying their farmers on credit and he could not sleep. On the Saturday he had found Father Brock out here on the bluff with his breviary, and Father Brock had closed it on a finger and looked at him.

You make a nice retreat, Norbert. Some year, make the Exercises. All of them. Thirty days.

Norbert had laughed. Thirty days. Purina gave him two weeks a year and he had a mortgage on Delor Street. Father Brock had laughed too, and opened his book again.

It came to Norbert at the rail that Father Brock had said it to him once and never again, and that in four months nobody alive would ever have said it to him at all. He had heard the page in the black book read fifteen times. He did not know that he had ever once done what it said.

That night he told Agnes what he was going to do. She sat at the kitchen table a long time. Then she asked who was going to cut the grass.

II. The Bouquet

South St. Louis · April and May

The retreat captains met on Tuesday nights in Al Huelsmann's basement among the pipe fittings, and by the end of April they knew what they were going to do. They were going to give Father Brock a spiritual bouquet.

Every Catholic child in St. Louis knew what that was. You did not send flowers, or not only flowers. You sent a card, and on the card was written what you had offered up for the person: so many Masses heard, so many Communions, so many rosaries, so many Stations of the Cross, so many visits to the Blessed Sacrament, so many of the little one-line prayers the Sisters called ejaculations. Al's idea was to send the cards to every parish that sent men to the White House, forty-one parishes. The Holy Name

men and the sodalities and the schoolchildren of the Notre Dame Sisters would fill them in, and the captains would add the whole thing up.

Frank Dunne, a bookkeeper at Anheuser-Busch, brought home an adding machine from the brewery. The cards came back by the hundred. By the middle of May the bouquet stood at 11,206 Masses, 9,840 Communions, 41,315 rosaries, 3,077 Stations of the Cross and 312,000 ejaculations, which the schoolchildren had counted on their fingers and the Sisters had certified. A bookbinder on Cherokee Street bound the cards in red leather and stamped the rosaries on the cover in gold.

There were real flowers too. By May the Sisters of St. Mary at Firmin Desloge had stopped carrying them into his room and were sending them on to the charity wards, and there were still lilies on the radiator. The captains made a list and came two at a time every evening, so that Father Brock was never alone. When the Sisters would not let them in, they sat on the bench in the corridor with their hats on their knees and asked each other in low voices who would give the retreats now. *What are we going to do.*

They planned a testimonial dinner for the twenty-second of June, seven hundred men at the Chase Hotel. They wanted to give him a car. The Father Provincial wrote to Al, very kindly, that a Jesuit under a vow of poverty had no use for a Buick, so they took up a collection for an oil portrait for the White House dining room instead.

Norbert Vogt's name was not on the list for the corridor bench. He did not come to the basement on Tuesdays. Al telephoned the house on Delor Street and got Agnes.

He's on a retreat, Agnes said.

He was on a retreat. In March. With me.

He's on another one.

III. Number Seventeen

The Coral Court, Watson Road · May

He had his two weeks of vacation, and he asked the general sales manager for sixteen days more without pay. He said it was a

FAMILY MATTER. AGNES SAID THAT WAS A LIE AND NORBERT said it was not. He went to the Jesuit residence at the university and asked for a priest to give him the Exercises, and the Father Minister, when he had stopped looking surprised, gave him Father Gallagher, who was thirty-four and taught chemistry, and had made the thirty days twice, as every Jesuit does, and never once given them.

The book said a man making the Exercises would profit more the more he separated himself from friends and acquaintances, leaving his house for another room where he could get to Mass each day and nobody he knew would get in his way. Norbert could not afford a month in a hotel downtown. So he took a room by the week at the Coral Court Motel, out on Watson Road where Watson Road was Route 66, twenty minutes from his own front door, because it was cheap and because nobody he knew would ever admit to having been inside it.

Everybody in St. Louis knew what it was. The Coral Court was a long curve of low yellow buildings in the trees, two rooms to a building, each room with its own garage, so that a man could drive in and pull the door down behind him and nobody going by on the highway would see his car. The walls were glazed tile the color of egg yolk, with brown trim, and the windows were glass block. The man at the desk gave him the key to Number 17, looked at the one suitcase, looked past him at the empty seat of the Pontiac, and said, *Anybody joining you?*

No, said Norbert.

The man at the desk had heard that before.

He went in on Monday, the ninth of May, and pulled the garage door down behind him, and for thirty days he did not speak except to a priest. He walked a mile up Watson Road every morning to the six-thirty Mass among the old ladies. He prayed five hours a day, an hour at a time, on the one hard chair, and when an hour was bad he sat it out to the end, because the book warned that the enemy was not a little used to making a man cut it short. At seven every evening Father Gallagher came and sat on the end of the bed, because Norbert had the chair, and gave him the points for the next day in about ten minutes, and left.

The first week was sin. The book told him to choose a single fault and keep account of it. He was to draw a mark like a large G with a line after it, and a second line under the first, and every time he fell he was to make a dot on the line, the first line for the morning and the second for the afternoon. He used the backs of Purina order blanks, which had the checkerboard printed in the corner. His fault was that he said more than was so. He had sold feed for twenty years by saying a little more than was so, about the feed and the other company's feed, and about himself, and to Agnes. On the first morning there were eleven dots on the first line by noon. Each time he caught himself he was to put his hand on his breast, which the book said could be done in front of a crowd without anyone noticing. There was no crowd in Number 17. He put his hand on his breast eleven times and felt like a fool all eleven.

The second week was the life of Christ. He sat in the yellow room with the light coming in through the glass block wavy and gold, as through water, and tried to see the stable at Bethlehem, and saw the cow lots of Pemiscot County and the dealers' boys throwing sacks of Chow onto trucks. Father Gallagher said that was all right. That was where most people saw it. There was a page in the book for men who were already married and could not choose a new life. In place of a choice it gave them a reckoning: how large a house to keep, how to teach and rule it by word and by example, how much to take for the household and how much to give to the poor. Norbert spent four days on that page and filled both sides of nine order blanks.

By the third week, the Passion, his sister-in-law Hildegard had told the Altar Society that Agnes had told her that Norbert was out at the Coral Court, and that she did not care what kind of a retreat Agnes wanted to call it. By the Holy Name breakfast on the first Sunday in June it was all over the parish.

IV. Desloge

Grand Avenue · the second of June

On Thursday afternoon Al Huelsmann and Frank Dunne drove out Watson Road in Al's plumbing truck, because they had decided that somebody had to. They walked the curve reading numbers and knocked at Number 17, and Norbert opened the door in his shirtsleeves.

Al had a speech ready. He had worked on it in the truck. When he saw the room he forgot it. The bed was made as tight as a barracks bed. On the dresser stood the crucifix from Norbert's bedroom at home, propped against the mirror, and next to it an order pad and a little black book, and nothing else. There was no woman. There was no bottle. There was no sign that anybody had been in that room but a man and a chair.

Norbert, Al said. *He's been asking. Seventy of us on that bench, and you never came once. Not once.*

Norbert looked at the two of them. He did not say anything. Then he went and got his hat.

Father Brock had a room high in Desloge looking east over the roofs toward the river. The Sisters had cleared out most of the flowers, but there were still lilies on the radiator and peonies in a milk bottle on the sill, and on the bed table lay the red leather album with *41,315 Rosaries* on the cover in gold. He was yellow now, and smaller in the bed than seemed possible for so big a man. Five or six of the captains were on the bench in the corridor. They got up and came and stood in the doorway.

Norbert, said Father Brock. *Where have you been?*

Norbert stood at the foot of the bed with his hat in his hands. Then he took a pencil and an order blank out of his shirt pocket and wrote on the back of the blank and handed it over.

Father Brock held it out at arm's length, because his glasses were somewhere. *Making the Exercises. Coral Court, No. 17. Day 25. You said July.*

He began to laugh. He laughed until a Sister came in from the corridor, and then he coughed, and she held the basin, and when he could talk again he waved her off and lay back with the order blank on his chest.

Al, he said. *How many rosaries?*

Forty-one thousand three hundred and fifteen, Father.

I'm grateful. I mean it. I'll need every one of them where I'm going. He turned his head on the pillow toward the men in the doorway. *And the flowers, and the dinner, and the picture. I'm not too proud for any of it. But I stood up in that chapel twenty-four years and told you men what you were made for, and here is the one who went and did it. Al, hand me my book. It's in the drawer.*

Al found it in the drawer of the bed table. Father Brock found the page without looking, the way a man finds the light switch in his own house, and read it to them in a voice not much above a whisper.

> *In these he will, ordinarily, more benefit himself, the more he separates himself from all friends and acquaintances and from all earthly care, as by changing from the house where he was dwelling, and taking another house or room to live in, in as much privacy as he can, so that it be in his power to go each day to Mass and to Vespers, without fear that his acquaintances will put obstacles in his way.*
>
> *— Spiritual Exercises, Twentieth Annotation*

He closed the book on his finger.

Love ought to be put more in deeds than in words. That's in here too. Any of you who love me, I don't need your Buick. Do what he's doing.

Then he looked at Norbert.

Go on back to your motel.

V. The Contemplation

Route 66 and the Bootheel · June to August 1949

On the last day, the seventh of June, Norbert got up at five and did not go to Mass right away. He sat in the chair in Number 17 with the book open to the Contemplation to Gain Love. The light came up behind the glass block, grey and then yellow, the color of the tile, and the trucks began on Route 66, one, then another, then too many to count,

carrying whatever they were carrying to Joplin and Tulsa and the coast. The book told him to look at how God dwells in creatures: in the elements, giving them being, in the plants, giving them growth, in the animals, giving them feeling, in men, giving them understanding, and so in him. He looked. He saw the trucks and the yellow tile and his own two hands on his knees, and for about as long as it takes a cup of coffee to go cold there was nothing in Number 17 that had not been given to him, and nothing in it he wanted to keep. Then he said the prayer at the end of the page, the one that gives back to God a man's liberty and his memory and his intellect and all his will, and walked up Watson Road to Mass.

The man at the desk took back the key. *Have a good time?*

Yes, said Norbert. It was the first word he had said out loud in thirty days to anybody but a priest.

• • •

The dinner at the Chase went on without Father Brock on the twenty-second of June. He sent word by Father Gallagher that the men should eat, and seven hundred of them ate. He died on Friday, the eighth of July, four months less five days after he had told them, and was buried from the College Church on Grand Avenue with the red album under his hands. The portrait, when it was finished, did not look like him at all.

That fall Al Huelsmann went to the Jesuit residence and asked for somebody to give him the Exercises the long way round, the way the book allows for a man with a business to run, an hour and a half a day for as many months as it takes. Frank Dunne went after him. By the next Lent there were nine of them, and Father Gallagher had written to the Provincial for help.

Norbert went back on the road. On a Tuesday in August he sat in the Pontiac outside the Purina dealer's in Sikeston at seven in the morning, before the store opened, with the windows down and the heat already coming up off the gravel and the checkerboard sign over the door. On the seat beside him lay an order blank. He drew a G on the back of it, and two lines after the G, one for the morning and one for the afternoon.

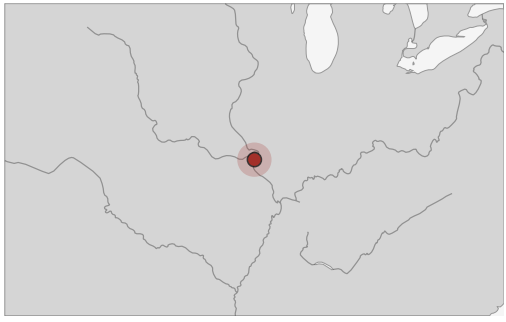
Then he went in to sell feed. A little before eight, talking with the dealer about the price of corn, he put his hand on his breast, and the dealer, who had known him twenty years, did not notice a thing.

Background

The verse

> *Let no one forget his own duty for the sake of another's, however great; let a man, after he has discerned his own duty, be always attentive to his duty.*
>
> Dhammapada 166, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha tells his monks that he will pass away in four months. Seven hundred monks who have not yet entered the stream are shaken, and they stay at his side, whispering to one another, *Friends, what are we to do?* Elder Attadattha (the name means "one's own good") thinks instead that he has not yet freed himself from the pollutants, and resolves to strive for arahatship with all his might while the Teacher still lives, so he stops keeping company with the others. They bring him before the Buddha as if he had done wrong. The Buddha praises him, says that those who honor him with perfumes and garlands do not truly honor him, and that only those who practice the Dhamma do, and speaks the verse. Attadattha reaches arahatship. Read the full commentary story, or about the Spiritual Exercises whose words stand in for the verse.



St. Louis, Missouri

St. Louis, 1949

Since 1922 the White House Jesuit Retreat has given three-day preached retreats, based on the Spiritual Exercises of Ignatius of Loyola, on an eighty-acre campus on the Mississippi bluffs south of St. Louis. Laymen who wanted more than one retreat

a year formed the first of the monthly Manresan clubs in 1921, and parish captains still recruit the men for each weekend. The full Exercises, in four "weeks," take about thirty days, and most laypeople who make them now do so in daily life, following Ignatius's Nineteenth Annotation, rather than by withdrawing for a month as the Twentieth describes. The translation quoted here is Father Elder Mullan's of 1914, from the Spanish autograph. Its Particular Examen tells the retreatant to mark on the lines of a G a dot for each time he falls into the fault he is working on. A spiritual bouquet is a Catholic gift of prayers rather than flowers: a card listing the Masses, Communions, rosaries and other devotions offered for someone.

The Coral Court Motel was built in 1941 on Watson Road, part of Route 66, in suburban Marlborough. Its two-unit buildings of yellow glazed tile and glass block, in the streamline moderne style, each had a garage, and, as Built St. Louis puts it, the motel "became famous for illicit encounters, as the individual garage units allowed one to park the car out of sight." It was demolished in 1995. Ralston Purina, which sold its animal feeds as "Chows," took its checkerboard from the four squares, physical, mental, social and religious, that its founder William H. Danforth drew in his 1931 book *I Dare You!* The Jesuits of Saint Louis University and the Sisters of St. Mary opened Firmin Desloge Hospital on Grand Avenue in 1933, about a mile south of the Jesuits' College Church.

After the story of Elder Attadattha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 166). The original. Scripture from the Spiritual Exercises of St. Ignatius, translated by Elder Mullan, S.J. (1914). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 13

The World

13.1

Cistern Water

> *Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful.*
> *— Psalm 1:1*

Is so I hear it, in Frederiksted.

I. After Hugo

La Grange, outside Frederiksted, St. Croix · October 1989

A MONTH AFTER THE STORM THE ISLAND STILL LOOKED LIKE something had lain down on it and rolled. Hugo had come over the island on the night of the seventeenth of September, and in the morning there were hardly any roofs. The galvanize was in the cane grass, in the mangroves, wrapped around the light poles like paper around a stick. The mahogany trees along Centerline Road stood with every leaf stripped off them and their bark peeled white on the windward side, and the flamboyants were down across the road with their roots in the air. Three days after, the troops had come, the first time soldiers had been sent into an American place for looting since anybody could remember, and now there were Humvees parked in front of the fort in Frederiksted and soldiers from somewhere cold sweating in the shade of the market.

There was no power and there would be none until Christmas, people said, or Easter, or never. There was no telephone. There was what was in the cistern.

Every house on St. Croix had one, a concrete tank under the floor or beside the house, filled from the gutters off the roof. In most yards now the roofs were gone and the gutters were gone and the rain that had

come with the storm had come down full of leaves and roof tar and dead lizards and grit, and so in every yard on the island someone was dipping a bucket on a rope down into the dark and pouring what came up through a cloth.

In Mama Cinth's yard it was her granddaughter.

Hyacinth Christian was sixty-eight and had been born in that house, and her mother before her, and she had lost her husband to the sea in 1971 and found the livity a year after, and nobody on the west end had stopped talking about it for ten years. A Crucian woman, a Moravian, a widow with a pension, gone and put her hair up in a wrap and turned Rasta. Now she was simply Mama Cinth, and her kitchen was where the brethren ate.

It had always been so. Before the storm and after it, in the morning there was porridge on her coal pot, cornmeal or peanut, and a stack of johnnycake, and bush tea, and whoever came up the hill was fed. She had cooked on the coal pot under the genip tree for twenty years because she liked it better than the stove. Hugo had taken her roof, her porch, her fowl coop and the whole top of the genip tree, and had left the coal pot sitting in the yard as if nothing had happened, and so the only thing that had changed in Mama Cinth's kitchen was that more people came. On the wall inside, under a blue tarp that slapped all night in the wind, she still had the fan of peacock feathers her husband had brought her from a ship, twelve of them in a jar, and they had come through without one eye missing. People came to look at them.

Keisha was fourteen. Her father was Mama Cinth's son Lloyd, a sergeant in the Virgin Islands Police, and since the storm he had been working shifts that ran into each other, beside the Guard and the soldiers, and her mother was a nurse at the hospital and slept there more nights than not. So Keisha was at her grandmother's. She had pressed her hair the Saturday before the storm, for a party that never happened. A month later, with no current for the iron and the air wet as a sponge, it stood up off her head in a way she would not look at.

II. The Calabash

The yard · a Tuesday morning

Brother Isaac came up the hill at seven with the youth. Isaac was a carpenter, a quiet big man with grey in his beard and locks to the backs of his knees bound up in a red, gold and green crown, and since the storm he had been on one roof after another from sunup, nailing down tarp the government brought in and galvanize people found in the bush. The youth was called Dervon. He was seventeen and had come to the elders in the spring, and his locks were six months grown, little tight knots all over his head that you could see the scalp between. A nubbie, they called it. That was the word for one just starting. He was proud of every one of them.

Isaac ate a bowl of porridge standing up. Then he said there was a widow down the road with the rain coming in on her bed, and he put a stool under the genip tree for the youth and told him to sit and eat and wait, and went on down the hill with his hammer through his belt.

Mama Cinth was in the cookhouse. Keisha brought the water.

She did it the way her grandmother had shown her, the bucket let down on the rope into the cistern and hauled up hand over hand and set on the step, and a square of old sheet tied over the mouth of a calabash bowl, and the water poured through slow so the cloth could catch what it caught. The cloth had been white once. When she took it off, the water in the calabash was dark and still, and there was her face in it, looking up at her, with her hair standing out all round it like a dandelion gone to seed.

She laughed. She could not help it.

Dervon leaned over to see what she was laughing at, and saw, and laughed too.

That was all. If either of them had been a year older or a year younger it would have stopped there. But she heard him laughing at her hair, and she stood up with the calabash in her two hands and said, loud, for the yard to hear, *Look the nubbie laughing.*

His face shut like a door.

You a baldhead, he said. *And your mother is a baldhead. And your father is a baldhead too, and a Babylon besides.*

It was the worst thing he knew how to say, and it was true, every word of it, which made it worse. She put the calabash down on the step so hard the water jumped, and ran into the cookhouse crying.

Grannie.

What happen, baby?

She told it. Mama Cinth wiped her hands on her skirt and came out to the genip tree.

III. Nubbie

Under the genip tree

YOUTH, SHE SAID. *DON'T VEX. SIT DOWN. SHE DON'T MEAN YOU NO harm. Nubbie is no bad word. Nubbie is the youth whose locks just start to grow for the Most High. It mean you take the vow. Is the Nazarite word, Numbers six.* And she said it to him, standing in the yard with her wrap on her head, because she had said it so many times by now to people who asked her why.

> *All the days of the vow of his separation there shall no razor come upon his head: until the days be fulfilled, in the which he separateth himself unto the LORD, he shall be holy, and shall let the locks of the hair of his head grow.*
>
> *— Numbers 6:5*

Mama, I know what nubbie mean, said Dervon. *I know the vow. I know is a holy thing to be. But is right for she to laugh after me and call me so?*

Mama Cinth looked at him and looked back at the cookhouse, where her granddaughter was crying on a crate with her face in her arms, and she could not make either one of them right. She went back and forth between them twice. She brought him another johnnycake. She brought Keisha a cup of the bush tea. Neither one would take it.

Then Brother Isaac came back up the hill for his level, which he had left, and stopped in the gate.

What going on, Mama?

She told him. Isaac set down his hammer and looked at the youth.

Dervon. Hush. That is no insult. That is what you are. A nubbie is a man who take the vow and his locks is small yet. Hold your peace.

Brother, I know that. But why you rebuke me? Why you don't rebuke she? Is right to laugh after a man's locks?

Isaac opened his mouth and closed it again. In the cookhouse Keisha had stopped crying to listen.

IV. The Seat of the Scornful

The same morning

Elder Absalom came up the hill a little after eight. He was past seventy and walked with a stick of guava wood, and he had come up from Jamaica in the last years of the cane to cut it, and stayed when the cane was gone, and grown his locks white. He did not come to the yard every day. When he came, the yard went quiet, the way a yard goes quiet when the wind drops. He had his own breakfast in a pan wrapped in a cloth, a piece of roast breadfruit and a little saltfish, and he set it on the step.

Greetings, Mama. What happen here?

Mama Cinth told it from the beginning. The bucket, the cloth, the calabash, the face, the laugh, the word, the other word, the crying, and Isaac. The elder listened all the way through with both hands on top of his stick and looked at the youth on the stool for a long time while she talked. He saw a boy who wanted very badly for somebody to be on his side, and he saw what was behind that, and he decided.

Sister, he said to Mama Cinth, quite stern. *Is right for your granddaughter to laugh after my youths, because their locks small yet? Because they take the vow and it don't show plenty? Call them nubbie for a joke in the yard?*

Dervon was on his feet before the elder finished. He put his two hands together in front of him like a man in church.

Elder. You alone overstand it. Not Brother Isaac. Not Mama. You alone.

The elder nodded slowly, as if agreeing. Then he looked at the youth's two hands held together and did not let him sit back down.

Now hear me, youth. Two of you laughed over a face in the water. Her face, her hair, how it look. Then she laugh over your hair and you laugh over her mother and father. All of that is the one same thing. To laugh after the flesh, how it look, how it grow, who it belong to. That is a low road. A man who take the vow don't walk that road at all. Not to give, not to take back. And don't sit down with carelessness. Carelessness is a easy seat. Plenty people sitting there.

Then he said the psalm. He did not take out a Bible. He had it the way the old people have a psalm, all the way down, and he said the first three verses of it in the yard with the stripped genip tree over his head and the tarp slapping on the house behind him, and Isaac said it along with him under his breath, and so after a while did Mama Cinth.

> *Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful. But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night. And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper.*
>
> *— Psalm 1:1–3*

Dervon stood with his hands still together. Something went across his face that the people in the yard remembered afterward and could not describe, the way you cannot describe the moment a cistern bucket stops swinging on its rope and hangs straight. The elder saw it. He sat down on the step and unwrapped his breadfruit.

The youth went over to the calabash where Keisha had put it down. The water had settled. He looked into it a long time and saw his own face, and the little knots of his locks all round it with the light between, and he did not laugh, and he did not stop looking, either. Then he carried the calabash to the cookhouse door and held it out to her with both hands.

Sister. I thank you for the water.

She took it from him and did not know what to do with it, and drank some, and gave it back.

• • •

Before he left, Elder Absalom pointed with his stick at the genip tree. The storm had stripped it to the wood a month before, every leaf, and everyone had said it was dead. Along the broken limbs, if you stood close, there were new leaves coming out, small and folded and a green so pale it was nearly yellow, hundreds of them, all the way up.

Keisha strained the next bucket at noon. She tied the square of sheet over the calabash and poured slow, and the water came through clear, and when she untied the cloth it was brown in the middle with what it had caught, leaves and grit and a little roof tar. She rinsed it as well as she could and pegged it on the line between the genip tree and the house to dry for the next time, and it hung there grey all afternoon in the wind, under the new leaves.

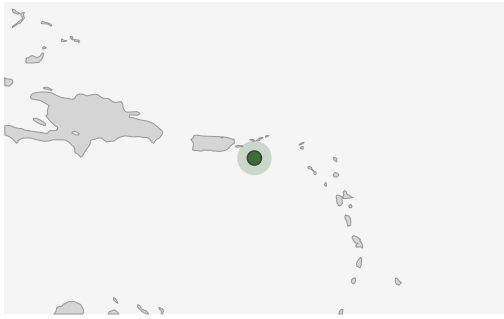
Background

The verse

> *Do not follow the evil law! Do not live on in thoughtlessness! Do not follow false doctrine! Be not a friend of the world.*
>
> Dhammapada 167, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, an elder brings a young monk to breakfast at the house of Visākhā, the Buddha's great lay patron, where cakes and rice gruel are always being given out, and goes on to another house. Visākhā's granddaughter, straining water for the young monk, sees her face in the water-pot and laughs; he laughs too. She calls him a "cut-head," and he answers that she is a cut-head and so are her mother and father. She runs crying to her grandmother. Visākhā tells him the word is a mark of respect for a monk whose hair and nails and robe are cut short, but he will not be calmed, and when his elder returns and rebukes him he asks why the girl is not rebuked instead. Then the Buddha arrives, hears the story, and, seeing the young monk is ready, first asks Visākhā whether it is proper for her granddaughter to call his

monks cut-heads. The young monk springs up and says only the Buddha understands. The Buddha then tells him that ridicule over the pleasures of the senses is a low thing, not to be taken up, and that one should not live with heedlessness, and speaks the verse; the young monk enters the stream. Read the full commentary story, or about Visākhā.



Frederiksted, St. Croix, U.S. Virgin Islands

St. Croix, 1989

Hurricane Hugo struck St. Croix on September 17–18, 1989, with gusts measured at up to 168 miles an hour. More than 90 percent of the island's buildings were damaged and power and water service failed. Looting spread in the days after, and at the governor's request federal troops, FBI agents and U.S. marshals were sent to the island, the first deployment of American troops in response to civil disorder since 1968. Fresh water is scarce in the Virgin Islands, and most houses and businesses on St. Croix collect rainwater from their roofs in built-in cisterns.

Rastafari arose in Jamaica in the 1930s and spread through the Caribbean and its diaspora. Rastas call their way of life "livity"; it includes the Ital diet and wearing the hair in dreadlocks, which Rastas trace to the Book of Numbers and to the hair of Samson, and see as a mark of their covenant with Jah. Rastas often call non-Rastas "baldheads," and someone who has only just begun to grow locks is a "nubbie." In July 2025 the government of the Virgin Islands proclaimed a Rastafari Day and issued a formal apology for decades of ridicule, profiling and persecution (St. Croix Source).

After the story of a certain young monk from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 167). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

13.2

Better Than Sleep

Prayer is better than sleep!
— the call to morning prayer, tr. E. W. Lane

Hayk smi'naha, on Harlem Avenue.

I. Sedlak's

Bridgeview, Illinois · April 1990

Hajj Musa Barakat came to Chicago in 1956 with one suitcase, and by 1990 he owned the banquet hall on Harlem Avenue. In between there had been a grocery on Forty-Seventh Street, then three groceries, then five, then a brick two-flat in Gage Park, and, when the stores had gone to his nephews, the hall. He bought it in 1984 from a Bohemian family and left their name on the sign, SEDLAK'S BANQUETS, because the sign was paid for and the Lions Club knew where it was. Inside he changed everything. He hung chandeliers from a hotel sale downtown and put a fountain in the lobby that ran pink on wedding nights, and he had chairs for six hundred. In the southwest suburbs people who had never learned his name called him Abu Tariq, father of Tariq. People who had known the family in Beitunia remembered that his grandfather had been mukhtar of the village under the Turks, and that a Barakat did not carry his own packages.

Tariq was the eldest, born over the first store. At nineteen he went to Cairo to study at al-Azhar for two years, and he stayed nine. Letters came, and then cassettes, carried home by men who had been on the pilgrimage or at a cousin's wedding in Amman. On the cassettes a young man recited the Qur'an, and people listening in parked cars outside the mosque left the engine running to hear the end of the chapter. By the last years the

men on Ninety-Third Street were saying Shaykh Tariq. Abu Tariq let them.

He came home in Ramadan, which fell in April that year. Fourteen cars went to O'Hare. He came out of customs with one bag, a thin man of twenty-eight in a gray robe and the red cap with a white cloth wound around it that the Azharis wear, and the family went at him in a wave. His uncles Ismail and Dawud stayed back by the baggage carts with their arms folded. They had held him at his circumcision. Dawud had taught him to ride a bicycle in the alley off Kedzie. They were glad to see him, and they were not going to kiss the hand of a boy.

He did not come to the house. In the last ten nights of the month a man who is able stays in the mosque. He rode from the airport in his father's Lincoln to Ninety-Third Street, carried his bag inside, and slept on the carpet among the old men.

II. The Lot

The mosque on Ninety-Third Street · the twenty-seventh night

THE MOSQUE STOOD BETWEEN THE RAILROAD TRACKS AND A trailer park, on the lot the first families had been able to afford, and it held three hundred. On the twenty-seventh night more than a thousand came. Rugs and bedsheets and flattened cartons were laid on the asphalt between the cars. When the night prayers were finished one of the elders asked the visitor to give the lesson.

The uncles had prayed in the front row inside, where they always prayed. They came out and stood at the back of the lot beside Dawud's Oldsmobile with their hands clasped behind them, like men who mean to listen for a few minutes to be polite.

It is told a few ways. The Barakats tell it one way and the families from the other villages another, and a woman who lived then in the third trailer from the fence, who is not a Muslim, will tell it to anybody. They agree on this much. He began in the ordinary manner, standing on the ground by the door. Somewhere in the first quarter hour he started to walk while he talked, up the lot and back, and he was not on the asphalt. He was as

high as the roofs of the cars and then as high as the light poles, going back and forth over the people at an easy pace with his hands behind him, the way a man walks the length of a roof in the evening. There was something under his feet where he walked. Some of the families say it looked like the colored glass of the lamps in an old mosque. The woman from the trailer park says it was like the lit top of a jewelry counter, the whole length of the lot, red and green and a yellow like egg yolk, and that a freight on the tracks behind her stood still until he came down.

He came down by the door. Abu Tariq went forward through the rows in his stocking feet, and in front of everyone he knew he took his son's right hand, kissed it, and touched it to his forehead, as a son does with a father. Ismail came next. Then Dawud, who was weeping and angry about it. Then everybody.

Then it rained. It came hard for some minutes out of a sky that still had stars along one edge, and people ran for the cars. Afterward, in the doorway, they held out their sleeves to one another. Some were wet through to the undershirt. Others, who had stood shoulder against shoulder with them on the same bedsheet, were dry, and the dry ones were those who had on the new clothes they had bought for the feast. They were loud about it. Tariq, wringing the hem of his robe, said it was not the first rain to fall on this family.

In Beitunia, under the Turks, there was a Barakat who could not keep anything. My father knows which one. The family had a white mule, and in a dry year, wherever that mule was lent for the threshing, rain came after. People from across the wadi asked him for it when their cisterns were dust, and he gave them the halter. So his brothers put him out. He lived in a watchman's hut in the olives. He gave away the seed wheat they sent up to him, and then his blanket, and in the end the door off the hut, to a man who said he needed a door. When the brothers climbed up to bring him home, because nothing had gone right for them since, it rained on all of them where they stood. That kind of rain. Whoever wanted it got it.

Abu Tariq knew which one. It was his grandfather's uncle, and the family did not tell that story.

III. Six Hundred Chairs

Sedlak's Banquets · the same night

It was past one when the lot emptied. Everyone had to be up again before four to eat ahead of the fast, and everyone went home. Each family, pulling out onto Harlem, supposed that a man whose father owned a banquet hall did not need to be asked. Ismail supposed Dawud had asked him. Dawud was still wiping his face. Abu Tariq thought, *If my son does not eat at my table, where will he eat?* and so he did not ask him either. He drove to the hall.

He had been planning it for a week. The next night's breaking of the fast was to be the Shaykh's dinner, for the whole community, at his expense. Twenty lambs had been in the ovens since the evening prayer. Three hundred pounds of rice stood soaking, and the cooks were breaking dried yogurt from Jordan into the big kettles, because it was going to be mansaf and it was going to be remembered. There were sixty round tables of ten, with a pitcher and a dish of dates on each. On the low stage where the bride and groom sat at weddings he had set one table apart with the two gilt chairs, and then he had one of the gilt chairs carried away.

At twenty past three he was in the kitchen with a spoon in the broth when the wall telephone rang.

IV. The Round

Palos Hills · before dawn

Tariq woke on the mosque carpet a little before three. The men who were keeping the ten nights there had their trays from home, brought in by sons and grandsons. Nobody had thought to bring one for him.

He sat a while and considered it. For nine years he had lived in two rooms behind al-Azhar, in the Batniyya quarter, and for nine Ramadans he had walked that quarter at night with its waker. This was an old man called Amm Sayyid, who had the round from his father, who had it from

his. The first years Tariq carried the lamp for him. The last years, when the old man's hands shook, he carried the drum. He asked himself what Amm Sayyid did when he came into the quarter on the first night, and what the wakers before him had done. They did not go first to the house of a relative. They began at the first door of the first lane and went on in order to the last, passing by only a house in mourning, and they ate what was handed out to them.

He took the drum out of his bag. It was most of what was in the bag, a copper bowl no bigger than a soup dish with a skin laced over it, and a leather strap to beat it with. He borrowed the flashlight from the mosque kitchen and walked a mile south in the dark to the subdivision where his father lived.

It was called Fontaine Bluff. It had been built in 1974 by a man who named the cul-de-sacs in French after his daughters, Cour Denise, Cour Annette, Cour Lorraine. At the entrance was a fieldstone sign, and under the name hung a smaller board that the homeowners' association had voted on, NO SOLICITING.

The first house inside the entrance belonged to a family from Beitunia named Mansour. Tariq stood at the foot of the driveway and beat the drum three times with the strap. It made a small dry sound. Then he called what Amm Sayyid called. The words are old. An Englishman who lived in Cairo in the 1830s heard them under his own window and wrote them down like this: *He prospereth who saith "There is no deity but God."* Three beats more. *The most happy of nights to thee, O Abu Khalil.*

A light came on upstairs. The front door opened and Abu Khalil Mansour stood in it in his undershirt, sixty years old, with his mouth open. He had not heard that drum since he was a boy in his mother's house. His wife came up behind him with a boiled egg and half a round of bread with oil and thyme on it. Tariq thanked her and ate them standing in the driveway, and went on to the next house.

The next house was Mrs. Gorski's. She was eighty-one and had been awake since two, as she was every night, and her kitchen light was on. He did not beat the drum for her. He stood for a moment at the end of her

walk, as he had been taught to stand a moment at every door, and she came out in her housecoat to see what the noise was.

You're Mr. Barakat's boy. The priest.

Something like that.

Have you eaten?

She brought him a slice of poppy seed roll on a paper towel and stood there until it was finished.

So it went, door after door in order. The Hamdans gave him three dates and tea in a paper cup. At a dark house he stood his moment and walked on. A man named Dykstra, just home from the night shift at the corn plant in Argo, was sitting in his truck with the dome light on, finishing his Thermos. He rolled the window down, asked if this was a religious thing, and handed out an orange. The Salehs had cold kibbeh. At a house where the grandfather had died in February Tariq put the strap in his pocket and went by with his hand on his chest. Dr. Aziz the dentist came out angry about the hour and the neighbors, went back in, and came out again with cheese folded in bread.

By Cour Denise a Palos Hills squad car had come up behind him with its headlights off and was following at a walk. By Cour Annette his brother Nabil was there. Nabil was to be married the week after the feast, to a girl from Burbank, and their mother had sent him in his car to bring Tariq home. At some doorstep Tariq had handed him the flashlight, to free a hand for a glass of milk, and walked on. Now Nabil was coming along behind in his good shoes, holding the light, because he could not see how to give it back.

Behind them the windows were lit in order, house by house, and ahead they were dark. People stood on their front steps in bathrobes. Some of the old ones were crying, and some of the young ones wished to be dead. Children in pajamas sat down on the curb. The telephones that ordinarily carried deaths and engagements were carrying this.

V. The Lincoln

Cour Lorraine · ten past four

THE CALL TO THE HALL KITCHEN WAS FROM DAWUD. *MUSA. Your son is going door to door in Fontaine Bluff with a drum, like the waker of some alley in Cairo, and the Polish widow is feeding him cake.*

Abu Tariq went out through the lobby past the fountain. He had his camel overcoat half on over his shirtsleeves, and he was still working his arm into the second sleeve when he swung the white Lincoln onto Harlem Avenue. He drove the two miles with the coat bunched behind his shoulder.

He found them on his own court. His house was the fourth on Cour Lorraine, brick, with two concrete lions at the foot of the drive, and his son was standing at the third. Abu Tariq stopped the car in the middle of the turnaround and got out and left the door open, so that the chime went on ringing.

Tariq. He spoke low, in Arabic. *Why are you doing this to me? I am ashamed to the ground. In this town it would not be fitting for a son of mine to go from door to door in that car, with a driver. You go on foot and take bread from their hands. Why do you put me to shame?*

I am not putting you to shame, Yaba. I am keeping the custom of my line.

Your line. Abu Tariq looked at his own house. *Is it the custom of my line to get its bread at doors?*

No. That is not the custom of your line. Tariq wiped his fingers on his robe. *It is the custom of mine. Amm Sayyid had it from his father, and his father from the wakers before him, back and back to Bilal, who called while it was still night so the people would rise and eat. Not one of them went first to his cousin's house. They took every door in order, and they lived on what came out of it.*

Bilal was a slave.

Yes.

Abu Tariq had come to this country with a suitcase of tablecloths and bedspreads. He had gone up and down the three-flats of Forty-Seventh Street knocking, a dollar down and a dollar a week, at doors that mostly

did not open, and he had spent thirty years seeing to it that nobody who mattered would have to remember that. His son had been born over the store the suitcase bought. Tariq had said no, and he left it there.

It was close to the hour. Over on Ninety-Third Street the call would be going up inside the walls, where the neighbors did not hear it. Here there were porch lights, a squad car, and Mrs. Gorski coming up the sidewalk in her housecoat with the rest of the poppy seed roll. Tariq did not raise his voice. He said the end of the dawn call there in the turnaround, which everyone on those steps had heard every morning of their lives before they came to America.

> *Come to prayer! Come to security! Prayer is better than sleep!*
>
> *— the call to morning prayer, tr. E. W. Lane (1836)*

His father was still standing with one hand holding his coat shut. So Tariq gave him the rest, as the preachers of Cairo give it on a Friday from the pulpit stair.

> *O people! reverence God by doing what He hath commanded, and abstain from that which He hath forbidden and prohibited. The happy is he who obeyeth, and the miserable is he who opposeth and sinneth. Know that the present world is a transitory abode, and that the world to come is a lasting abode.*
>
> *— a Friday sermon of Cairo, tr. E. W. Lane (1836)*

Abu Tariq stood. Then he reached into the Lincoln and took the key out, and the chime stopped. He put his other arm through its sleeve and buttoned the coat to the neck. He held out his hand to Nabil for the flashlight, and Nabil gave it up gladly.

The officer in the squad car wrote in his log, *4:11, Cour Lorraine, religious observance, no complainant,* and backed out of the court.

At the fourth house, the brick one with the lions, Tariq beat the drum three times. *The most happy of nights to thee, O Abu Tariq,* he called to the man standing beside him with the light. Umm Tariq came down her own

front steps with a glass of milk and two dates on a saucer, and her son took them from her hand.

VI. The Drum

Fontaine Bluff · the Ramadans after

The dinner was eaten that night at Sedlak's. Six hundred chairs were not enough. Abu Tariq sent the busboys with covered trays to the trailer park by the mosque, to Mrs. Gorski, to the man Dykstra, and to the front desk of the Palos Hills police. Tariq ate at a round table by the kitchen door. Nobody sat in the gilt chair.

He stayed for the feast and for Nabil's wedding, and then he went where a teacher was wanted, to a storefront mosque in another state. He has students now who have students. He left the drum on the hall table in his father's house.

The next year Ramadan came eleven days sooner, as it does, and on its first night, at a quarter past three, the drum was heard in Fontaine Bluff. It was Abu Tariq in the camel coat, sixty-three years old, alone, starting at the Mansours' and taking every door in order. He kept it up nine years, until his knees would not do the hill on Cour Denise. He was never any good on the drum. People handed him eggs and bread, and he ate them in the driveways. The homeowners' association took the matter up once, under Noise, and Mrs. Gorski stood and said she had lived her whole life under church bells, and nobody moved the question. After she died her kitchen was dark, and he stood his moment at the end of her walk all the same.

On that first night alone, when he came to Cour Annette, Dr. Aziz's mother was at an upstairs window. She was a very old woman from Cairo, visiting on a six-month visa, and she did what the women of her street did when she was a girl. She folded a quarter into a piece of the *Southtown Economist* and lit the paper with a kitchen match, so that the waker would see where it fell, and let it go. It came down past the gutter, turning, a small fire. Abu Tariq stood over it on the driveway until it had burned

out. Then he picked his quarter out of the ash, put it in his coat pocket, and went on to the next door.

Background

The verses

> *Rouse thyself! do not be idle! Follow the law of virtue! The virtuous rests in bliss in this world and in the next.*
>
> Dhammapada 168, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Follow the law of virtue; do not follow that of sin. The virtuous rests in bliss in this world and in the next.*
>
> Dhammapada 169, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha makes his first visit home to Kapilavatthu. To break the pride of his kinsmen he walks up and down on a jeweled cloister in the air, and they bow to him, his father the king first. A shower falls on the gathering, and he tells them it has rained on his family before, in the life of the great giver Vessantara. They all go home, and no one invites him to eat; the king, sure his son can eat nowhere else, has food and seats made ready for twenty thousand without asking. Next morning the Buddha considers what the Buddhas before him did and goes from door to door through his father's city with his bowl. The king hurries out, pulling his cloak straight, and asks why he is being put to shame. The Buddha answers that begging is the custom of his line, the line of the Buddhas, and speaks the two verses. Read the full commentary story, or about Suddhodana and the Vessantara birth story.

Bridgeview and Palos Hills, Illinois

The southwest suburbs of Chicago, 1990

Palestinians in Chicago began as peddlers and shopkeepers on the South Side; by the early 1970s they owned nearly a fifth of the city's small groceries. In the 1980s many families moved out to Burbank, Oak Lawn, Hickory Hills, Bridgeview and Palos Hills. The Mosque Foundation, begun in 1954 by immigrants from the West Bank village of Beitunia, opened its mosque in Bridgeview in 1981 on a lot between railroad tracks and a trailer park, with a prayer hall for three hundred. The Barakats, Sedlak's Banquets and the Fontaine Bluff subdivision are invented. Ramadan in 1990 ran from late March to late April.

The night waker of Ramadan, the *musaharati* or *musahhir*, walks his quarter before dawn with a small drum to rouse people for the last meal before the fast, greeting householders by name, and is paid in food or in coins at the feast. Tradition names Bilal, the freed Abyssinian slave who was the first caller to prayer, as the first of them (see this account of the trade). Edward William Lane lived in Cairo in the 1820s and 1830s and described the waker in his *Account of the Manners and Customs of the Modern Egyptians*: the drum beaten three times, the greeting to each man of the house, the house of mourning passed by, and the women who wrapped a coin in paper and set the paper alight before dropping it from the window. The waker's cry, the words of the dawn call and the passage from a Friday sermon are quoted here in Lane's English, from the text of his fifth edition (1860).

After the story of Suddhodana from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 168 and 169). The original. The call to prayer, the waker's cry and the sermon from E. W. Lane, *An Account of the Manners and Customs of the Modern Egyptians* (1836; fifth edition 1860). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

13.3

Homo Bulla

> *If, as the saying is, all life is but a bubble, the more fragile is that of an old man.*
> *— Varro, On Farming I.1, tr. Fairfax Harrison*

Sic audivi, in Miami Springs.

I. Thirteen Lines

Hialeah High School, Florida · Tuesday, October 23, 1962

Miss Alma Rountree had taught Latin in Dade County for thirty-nine years, the last eight of them at the high school in Hialeah, where the children from Miami Springs also went, the Springs having no high school of its own yet. She was sixty-four. Her fourth-year class that fall was five. On the second Friday in October she slipped on the wet terrazzo of the breezeway and broke her hip, and by the time the President went on television she had been ten days gone, first in the hospital having a steel pin put in, then at home in the Springs, in bed, under orders not to stand before Thanksgiving.

She left two things behind her in Room 114. One was in the top corner of the blackboard, where every Monday she chalked a sentence for anyone who cared to take it home. That week's was from Varro, who wrote his book on farming at eighty, and under the Latin she had put the English in her square hand, out of a translation she liked by a Virginia railroad man.

Si est homo bulla, eo magis senex.

If, as the saying is, all life is but a bubble, the more fragile is that of an old man.

Nobody had erased it. The substitute, Mr. Purdy, taught driver education and did not like to touch the board.

The other thing was thirteen lines of Lucretius. Fourth year was Vergil, and they would get back to Vergil. But every October she took her seniors out of the *Aeneid* for two weeks and made them put into English the place in the third book where Lucretius says that death is nothing to us. Some years a parent telephoned about it. It began *Nil igitur mors est ad nos neque pertinet hilum,* and she had told them, the day before she fell, that *hilum* was the little dark mark on a bean where it had hung in the pod. Death did not concern us by the mark on a bean.

They had had ten days, and they could not do it.

They had the words. Sandra Lipscomb had every word on a card. Kenny Brandt, who built radios, said it was only atoms and he did not see the difficulty, and then could not write a sentence of it down. Dale Pruitt got as far as the Carthaginians. Midge Koenig said it was a terrible thing to hand to children. The fifth was María Elena Fuentes, who had come from Havana alone in March on the Pan American plane, sixteen years old, in the care of the Catholic Welfare Bureau, and who lived now with a family named Henderson on East Ninth Street. She read Latin better than any of them, from the nuns. Her English was eight months old. She had the thirteen lines by heart and said them under her breath between classes, and they would not come across.

That Tuesday was a hard day to work in. The President had been on at seven the night before. By the first bell the Food Fair on Palm Avenue was out of canned milk and bottled water, and Midge's mother had filled the bathtub. Twice before lunch fighters went over low toward Homestead, in fours, and the windows of Room 114 buzzed in their frames. There was an air raid drill at ten. Dale's father, who fueled airplanes for Eastern, had said at breakfast that an Air Force bomber was parked at the far end of the long runway. Mr. Henderson had said at his breakfast that the Havana flights were stopped. María Elena's mother and father had had their papers since June and were waiting for seats.

At the last bell the five of them stood in the breezeway where she had fallen and agreed to go and ask her for something else. Caesar, Dale said. Caesar building his bridge. A person could just translate Caesar.

II. Okeechobee Road

Hialeah · the same afternoon

Dale had his mother's Rambler. They went down Palm Avenue and out along the canal on Okeechobee Road, five in a station wagon with the windows down. It was eighty-four degrees, with the sun straight on the blacktop.

Ahead of them the road went under water. It lay bright and flat from the canal bank to the far curb, a quarter mile on, with the sky in it. A city bus coming toward them stood in it to the axles, and a second bus hung upside down beneath the first. Dale slowed, as he had on every hot afternoon since he got his license. The water drew back and kept its distance. The bus came up out of it dry and went by.

It's the heat, Kenny said. *The air right on the road is hotter than the air over it, and the light bends coming through. That's sky. You're looking at a piece of the sky laid down on the road.*

So it is truly there, María Elena said.

The sky is. The water isn't.

On the road to Varadero it is the same. She was looking out the side window, south, toward the airport. *My father also slows the car.*

Then how do you tell which things are the water? Midge said.

Nobody had anything for that. Sandra said you drove up to it. Dale drove up to it for another mile. It stayed the same quarter mile ahead of them, shining, with a palm tree standing on its head in it, and none of the five looked at anything else until the bridge. Then they crossed the canal into the Springs.

III. The Swale

Oriole Avenue, Miami Springs · twenty minutes to four

Miss Rountree lived with her sister Opal in a concrete-block house with a carport and a Florida room, on a lot with a sea grape by the front walk. A cloud had come up from the Glades side while they were on the bridge. The first drops struck the roof of the Rambler as Dale set the brake, big ones, far apart. By the time they were out of the car it was coming the way it comes in that country, all at once and straight down.

They ran, and they did not all run to the same place. Dale and Kenny got under the carport beside Miss Opal's Studebaker. Sandra made the front step, under the eave. Midge was caught at the sea grape and stayed under it. María Elena stood at the corner of the carport by the jalousie door of the Florida room, with the rain going past a foot from her face.

The ground there is a hand's depth of sand over rock, and water stands on it before it goes anywhere. Inside a minute the driveway was a finger deep. In the swale along the street, the low strip of grass the county leaves for the purpose, it stood deeper, and every drop that hit raised a bubble. They were perfect. Each was a dome of glass the size of a half-dollar, with the gray sky bent around it and the sea grape and, if you leaned, five small heads. It sailed a little way and was gone, and another stood in its place.

Bulla, María Elena said.

Homo bulla, said Kenny.

Midge, under the tree, said *eo magis senex,* and nobody laughed.

They have each told it since, and they tell it alike. Each of them, watching the swale, had the same thought about then and took it for a private one. A bubble was only the water, stood up for a second with a breath in it and the whole sky on its side. When it went, nothing had gone anywhere. Kenny Brandt. Sandra Lipscomb. A girl from the Vedado with a mother and father on the far side of ninety miles. Those stood up the same way, out of the same water. They kept looking.

Then Miss Rountree was on the carport.

She had on her gray school dress, with chalk on the right cuff. She stood without a cane, a little way from each of them, though they were in four different places, and the rain that blew in under the roof did not wet her. There was a light on her of the kind a slide projector throws, so that she was brighter than the afternoon. She looked into each face in turn, the way she did before she handed back a test. Then she looked down at the driveway and said what she could never pass a puddle without saying.

> *A pool of water of but a finger's depth,*
> *Which lies between the stones along the pave,*
> *Offers a vision downward into earth*
> *As far, as from the earth o'erspread on high*
> *The gulfs of heaven; that thus thou seemest to view*
> *Clouds down below and heavenly bodies plunged*
> *Wondrously in heaven under earth.*
>
> *— Lucretius, On the Nature of Things, Book IV, tr. William Ellery Leonard (1916)*

After that she said the thirteen lines. She said them in Latin, at the pace she always took, and the five have never agreed how it was that they had them in English as she went. What Kenny wrote that night on the back of his chemistry notebook is not far from the English of Mr. Leonard of Wisconsin, which stood on her shelf in the Everyman edition and which none of them had ever opened. Leonard has the end of it this way.

> *thus when we are no more,*
> *When comes that sundering of our body and soul*
> *Through which we're fashioned to a single state,*
> *Verily naught to us, us then no more,*
> *Can come to pass, naught move our senses then—*
> *No, not if earth confounded were with sea,*
> *And sea with heaven.*
>
> *— Lucretius, On the Nature of Things, Book III, tr. William Ellery Leonard (1916)*

The jalousie door cranked open beside María Elena. Miss Opal Rountree stood in it in an apron, wanting to know what five children were doing in her yard in a cloudburst. She said her sister was asleep. She had been asleep since two o'clock in the back bedroom with the fan on, and she could not have stood up if the house were afire. Miss Opal took them through to see, one at a time, on tiptoe. The room smelled of lavender water and wintergreen. She was asleep.

Nobody asked for Caesar. The rain quit eleven minutes after it started. They stood a while longer where they were, in five places on a wet lot in Miami Springs, and Dale Pruitt says it is the one time in his life he has known for certain that nothing was the matter.

IV. The Count

Hialeah High School · Wednesday, October 24

The Navy's line around Cuba went into force at ten the next morning, and at ten the school had its drill. Fourth period filed out into the inside corridor and got down along the lockers with their heads on their knees and their hands laced behind their necks. Mr. Boggs, the assistant principal, came along with the clipboard, counting backs.

He counted Room 114 three times, and three times he came out five short. They were there. They were sitting against the lockers between the typing class and the Spanish class with their heads up, and María Elena was saying the thirteen lines over, in English now, to see whether they still held. She says she waved at him. Mr. Boggs marked the five absent and went on down the hall. The absences were never cleared. They are on five transcripts yet: fourth period, October 24, unexcused.

On Sunday it was over, or people said it was. The fighters stayed at Homestead a good while. The flights from Havana did not start again. María Elena's mother and father came out on the airlift in March of 1966, three years and five months later, when she was a sophomore at Barry College, and she translated for them at the airport.

Miss Rountree came back after Christmas on two canes. The Varro was still in the corner of the board, since Mr. Purdy had never touched it,

and under it, in five hands, were the thirteen lines in English. She read them through, standing. She took the chalk and changed one tense. Then she left all of it up until June, the old man's bubble and what was written under it, and on the last day of school she wiped the board herself, top to bottom, and went home.

Background

The verse

> *Look upon the world as a bubble, look upon it as a mirage: the king of death does not see him who thus looks down upon the world.*
>
> Dhammapada 170, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred monks take a subject of meditation from the Buddha and go to the forest. They strive hard and get nowhere, and set out to ask him for a subject better suited to them. On the road they see a mirage and fix their minds on it. As they enter the monastery grounds it begins to rain, and standing here and there on the terraces they watch the bubbles rise and burst in the downpour and think, so does this self of ours. The Buddha, seated in his own room, sends out a radiant image of himself that seems to look into each face, and speaks the verse; they are freed where they stand. Read the full commentary story.

Hialeah and Miami Springs, Florida

Dade County, October 1962

President Kennedy announced on the evening of Monday, October 22, 1962, that Soviet missiles were in Cuba, and the naval quarantine took effect at ten on Wednesday morning (the Cuban Missile Crisis). South Florida, the nearest piece of the mainland, filled with fighters, troops and anti-aircraft missiles; stores were stripped of canned

goods, and schools ran air raid drills. Commercial flights between Havana and Miami stopped that week. They had carried, since December 1960, more than 14,000 unaccompanied Cuban children sent ahead by their parents under the Catholic Welfare Bureau's program later called Operation Pedro Pan. Parents left behind waited until the Freedom Flights began in December 1965. Hialeah High School opened in 1954 and took students from Miami Springs, an airline town beside the airport, until the Springs got its own school in 1964. The Weather Bureau's gauge at Miami International, a mile south of the story's driveway, recorded a high of 84 degrees and five hundredths of an inch of rain on October 23, the only rain of that week. Miss Rountree, her five students and their Room 114 are invented.

The Latin tag *homo bulla*, man is a bubble, was already an old saying when Varro used it at eighty to open his book on farming; the English is from Fairfax Harrison's *Roman Farm Management* (1913), which he signed "a Virginia Farmer" while president of the Southern Railway. Lucretius wrote his poem on atoms in the first century BC to free his readers from the fear of death. The pool in the street is in Book IV, among the tricks of sight, where he also explains how things send out thin images of themselves through the air; the lines on death are Book III, 838–842, and the passage opens at line 830 with the words the class could not get across. The English is William Ellery Leonard's verse translation of 1916, reprinted in Everyman's Library. The same pair of images, the mirage and the bubble, stands under another story in this series, set in the Mojave in 2008.

After the story of the five hundred monks who gained insight, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 170). The original. Lucretius from the translation of William Ellery Leonard (1916); Varro from Fairfax Harrison, *Roman Farm Management* (1913). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

13.4

Dead Air

> *…come, children, let us shut up the box and the puppets, for our play is played out.*
> *— Thackeray, Vanity Fair*

As it stands in the log, at the top of the Abbott Hotel.

I. The Proclamation

Ruby Wells, Nevada · Sunday, September 12, 1943

STATION KRWN · 250 WATTS · 1240 KILOCYCLES · PROGRAM AND OPERATING LOG · OPERATOR ON DUTY: E. LAIRD

6:00 A.M. Sign on. Anthem, from transcription. Plate current normal. Frost on the tower guys already.

11:00 First Methodist, by wire. Line good.

2:00 P.M. Remote from the courthouse steps. The Mayor proclaims the seven days from today through Saturday the eighteenth to be Lieutenant Wade Abbott Week in Ruby Wells. County quota in the Third War Loan is $410,000. Lt. Abbott, 7th Division, was hit at Attu in May and is out of the hospital on leave. He is presented with a key to the city, gilt, about a foot long. He says thank you and one other sentence, which the wind took.

2:11 Mr. C. B. Abbott, the Lieutenant's father, owner of this hotel and president of this company, announces that his son is to want for nothing in this town for the week. Also that he has had the floor show in the Sagebrush Room held over through Saturday at his own expense, to play

the bond rallies, and that Miss June Darrow of that show, taps and songs, has agreed to appear at each one with the Lieutenant.

2:14 Somebody puts a pasteboard crown on the Lieutenant, left over from the Elks' carnival. He leaves it on. Crowd estimated at nine hundred, which is most of us.

2:20 Return to studio. Remarks: he looks nineteen. He is twenty-four. He kept turning the key over to see what it was made of.

12:00 Sign off. Anthem.

II. The Week

Monday, September 13, to Saturday, September 18

MON. 8:00 RALLY, SAGEBRUSH ROOM, BY REMOTE. LT. ABBOTT speaks forty seconds. Miss Darrow, two choruses and a tap routine. I put the second microphone on the floor by her feet. The taps come over clean.

MON. 8:40 Miss Darrow comes up the four flights after the show to ask how it sounded. Told her, like a good fist on a key. She had me explain that. Nine years on the boats I knew every operator on the Lakes by his sending before he gave his call, and a hand is a hand. She says she has been on the road since she was fifteen, is twenty-seven, and sends twenty dollars a week to her mother in Scranton. She asks to see how a record is cut and watches a whole side.

TUES. 12:15 Rotary, by remote. The same. The Lieutenant still has the crown, in his blouse pocket now, folded.

WED. 12:00 Southern Pacific roundhouse, noon whistle. She dances on a baggage truck. Bond sales to date $171,000.

THURS. 7:30 High school gymnasium. Lt. Abbott excused from speaking at his own request. He stands.

FRI. 9:15 Remarks. He has not been out of this building since Monday except in his father's car to a rally and back. He takes his meals in the

Sagebrush Room and is at the front table for both shows, every night. People send drinks. The barber came up to him. His money is no good anywhere in the county, and they have started calling him the King, to his face, and he answers to it.

SAT. 2:00 Parade, described from the hotel marquee. The Lieutenant rides in Mr. Abbott's open Packard with the crown on, Miss Darrow beside him at the Treasury's request. The Stockmen's Association float is a gold paper saddle eleven feet high. Bond sales $388,000.

SAT. 12:00 Sign off. By the proclamation the week ends now.

III. The Eighth Day

Riverside Park band shell · Sunday, September 19

5:05 P.M. LT. ABBOTT AT THE CONTROL ROOM DOOR WITH HIS hair wet. He has been swimming in the Humboldt below the bridge, the first time he has been in water since the Aleutians, he says. Asks if we are carrying the band concert tonight. We are.

8:00 Remote, Riverside Park. Municipal Band, closing bond appeal. The floor show leaves on Number 27 at 11:40 for Reno. Miss Darrow is not on the bill. She is doing one number because he asked her. I set the floor microphone on the band shell planks myself. He is on a bench under the cottonwoods, front row. Cutting the whole program on a sixteen-inch blank for the Treasury report.

8:41:10 Miss Darrow, vocal, one chorus, with the band.

8:42:05 Taps begin. Floor microphone up.

8:42:51 Taps stop in the middle of a bar.

8:42:51 to 8:43:14. Dead air on the floor microphone, twenty-three seconds. The band plays on eleven bars, not knowing, and quits a man at a time.

8:43:14 Cut to studio. Mrs. Pease at the organ.

9:30 Dr. Kessler by telephone. She put her hand to her side like a person cut, sat down on the planks, and was gone before he got up the steps. He thinks an artery, and that it had been waiting on her since she was a child. Nothing anybody there could have done. Announcement held, by order of Mr. Abbott, until her mother is reached.

11:40 Number 27 on time. The show went without her.

12:00 Sign off. Disc marked No. 2,114 and shelved.

IV. After Sign-Off

The control room · Monday, September 20, ten past one in the morning

Carrier is off. This sheet is not for the Commission, and I will take it out of the binder.

The Lieutenant came up the four flights at 1:10. His father has been looking for him since nine. So have the Methodist minister and an Army doctor they got on the telephone from Reno. He told the night clerk he would not see any of them, and that there was one man in town who could do him any good, because one man had heard it right. Then he came up here.

You have it on a record. Play it.

Played No. 2,114 from 8:41. He stood at the turntable. At fifty-one seconds she stops. Played it again at his asking. He asked a third time, and before I set the arm down I said what I had to say. I put it here as near as I can.

I was nine years with the phones on before there was a voice on the air. I have heard a hand quit sending in the middle of a word. You know the man by his fist, and then there is only the carrier, and then not that. I kept count of most things in those days, and I lost count of that. There are two thousand one hundred platters in that closet, and on every one of them somebody stops. She stops on this one at fifty-one seconds past the minute. She will stop there every time you have me play it. Son, she has stopped more times than there are records, and you have stood where you are standing and cried over it more times than that. There is no meter on this board that will read it.

He did not ask how I knew that. I could not have told him. He sat down on the transcription cabinet and was quieter than he had been.

I told him not to go under in it. A man can drown in a thing like this, or he can come and look at how it is put together. I took him across the hall into Studio A and put all the lights on.

It is a bare room, eighteen by twenty-four, with egg cartons glued to the walls. I showed him the works. The coach and four that the children hear on Saturday mornings is two halves of a coconut in a tray of gravel and a strap of sleigh bells. The thunder is a sheet of tin on a nail. The rain is birdseed on a drumhead. There is a door in a frame that opens on nothing. The ten thousand people cheering are on a platter, and so are the one man laughing and the dog. Lieutenant Abbott Week came out of this room and a hundred and eighty feet of pipe on the roof, and I showed him that from the window, with the red lamp on top. He had the key in his hand again. I told him it was plaster. He said he knew that Tuesday.

I keep one book up here for the long nights. I read him the front of it and the back of it, standing at the glass.

> *As the manager of the Performance sits before the curtain on the boards and looks into the Fair, a feeling of profound melancholy comes over him in his survey of the bustling place.*
>
> *A man with a reflective turn of mind, walking through an exhibition of this sort, will not be oppressed, I take it, by his own or other people's hilarity.*
>
> *When you come home you sit down in a sober, contemplative, not uncharitable frame of mind, and apply yourself to your books or your business.*
>
> *— W. M. Thackeray, Vanity Fair (1848), "Before the Curtain"*

> *Ah! Vanitas Vanitatum! which of us is happy in this world? Which of us has his desire? or, having it, is satisfied?—come, children, let us shut up the box and the puppets, for our play is played out.*
>
> *— Vanity Fair, the last lines*

He looked a good while through the glass at the empty studio. Then he took the crown out of his blouse pocket, unfolded it, and set it on the sound table beside the coconuts.

He did not ask for the record again. I offered it to him. I told him it was glass under the lacquer, they are all glass since the aluminum went to the war, and that he would have to carry it flat. He put his hand out for it and then did not take it. He said it was hers and I should keep it where I kept the others.

2:35, he went down. I heard him knock at his father's door on the third floor.

V. Shelf Three

Station KRWN · later sheets

SEPT. 20, 6:00 A.M. SIGN ON. ANTHEM. PLATE CURRENT NORMAL.

7:15 Announcement of the death of Miss June Darrow, of Scranton, Pennsylvania, read by Lt. Abbott at his own asking. He read it level. Mrs. Pease played after.

SEPT. 26 Lt. Abbott reported back for duty. County closed the drive at $431,000.

NOV. 4, 1945 Wade Abbott on the board, first shift alone. He has the ear for it. I have him on Tuesdays and Thursdays and the Saturday children's hour, where he does the coach.

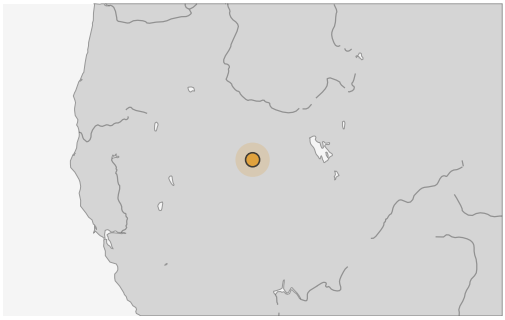
MAR. 9, 1946 Remarks. He asked today where No. 2,114 was. Told him the closet, third shelf, where it has been. He said all right. He did not go and look. He put the birdseed back in its can and pulled the switch at midnight himself.

Background

The verse

> *Come, look at this glittering world, like unto a royal chariot; the foolish are immersed in it, but the wise do not touch it.*
>
> Dhammapada 171, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Prince Abhaya puts down a rising on the frontier, and his father the king rewards him with the kingdom for seven days and with a celebrated dancer and singer for his court. For seven days he does not leave the palace. On the eighth he bathes at the river, sits down in his pleasure garden to watch her perform, and she is seized with cutting pains and dies as she dances. He is sure no one but the Buddha can put out his grief. The Buddha tells him there is no counting how many times she has died this way in the round of births, and no measuring the tears he has shed over her, and that only the simple sink in sorrow; then he speaks the verse of the painted chariot. Read the full commentary story.



Ruby Wells (fictional), Elko County, Nevada

A two-hundred-fifty-watt station, 1943

United States troops of the 7th Infantry Division landed on Attu, in the Aleutians, on May 11, 1943, and fought there in fog and snow until the end of the month. The Treasury's Third War Loan drive ran from September 9 to the beginning of October that year (see Series E bonds), with quotas down to the county, and towns built rallies, parades and "weeks" around any decorated man home on leave. Ruby Wells, its hotel and station KRWN are invented; the country is that of the Humboldt River and the Southern Pacific main line around Elko, Nevada.

Small stations of the time were required to keep a program log and an operating log for the Federal Communications Commission, minute by minute, and many recorded their own broadcasts on sixteen-inch lacquer discs, called electrical transcriptions.

During the war, when aluminum was a critical material, the discs were made on a glass core. Tap dancers really did perform on the air, with a microphone set at the feet. The sound effects in Studio A are the ordinary ones of the trade. A "fist" is a telegrapher's word for the personal rhythm of an operator's sending. The engineer's book is Thackeray's *Vanity Fair* (1848), whose narrator calls himself the manager of a puppet show at a fair; the passages are from its preface and its last paragraph, as in the Project Gutenberg text.

After the story of Prince Abhaya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 171). The original. Quotations from W. M. Thackeray, *Vanity Fair* (1848). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

13.5

The Push Broom

Give over thine own willing, give over thy own running.
— Isaac Penington, 1661

As it was given to me, at Plum Run Meeting.

I. Seven O'Clock

Cedar County, Iowa · Ninth Month 1998

Gene Aldinger mowed the meetinghouse lawn at seven on Seventh Day morning, and in a wet week he mowed it again on Fourth Day. He had taught industrial arts at the consolidated high school for thirty-one years and retired in the spring of 1994 with every one of his boys' fingers accounted for and nine and a half of his own. The half he had left in a jointer in 1971 with twenty-two sophomores watching. He had wrapped the hand in a shop towel, held it up so they could all see what a jointer does, and finished the period.

He was not a Friend. Marjorie was, birthright, Plum Run on both sides, and for forty years he had driven her out the gravel on First Day and sat beside her on the third bench with his hands on his knees, a Methodist waiting for somebody to start. When she died in the spring of 1996 the meeting buried her behind the old horse sheds under a stone no higher than a boot, and Gene kept coming. He did not know where else a man would go at ten o'clock on that day of the week.

What he did there was work. The meetinghouse was white frame, built in 1867, with two front doors from the time when the men went in by one and the women by the other, and there was by now no part of it he had not scraped, primed, caulked, rehung or replaced. He swept the meeting room in the morning and he swept it in the afternoon. He swept the

porch, the cloakroom, the basement stairs and the walk out to the mailbox. He had a twenty-four-inch push broom for which he had turned a new ash handle, and a corn broom for the corners. People going by on the blacktop at noon saw the green pickup in the lot, and going home at dusk they saw it again, and after a while nobody remarked on it.

On First Day he came at eight to turn up the furnace, and he was still in the basement when worship began. Friends sitting in the silence could hear him underneath them. A faucet ran. A stepladder opened. The push broom went the length of the dining room and came back. Nobody spoke to him about it. He was not a member, and the gutters had never been so clean.

II. The Facing Bench

A Fourth Day afternoon · Tenth Month

Lowell Mott was eighty-four and lived in the three-room cottage across the lot, which the meeting had built for a caretaker in 1951 and which had held no caretaker since Lowell's knees went. The meeting paid his light bill. The women of the meeting left covered dishes on his step, turn and turn about. Most days after his dinner he crossed the gravel on two canes, let himself in by the east door, sat down on the facing bench under the clock, and stayed there until the windows went gray.

Gene came into the meeting room that afternoon with the push broom, and there he was as usual, hat beside him, eyes down.

Gene stood in the doorway. He thought: That man eats the meeting's casseroles and burns the meeting's lights, and then he comes over here and sits. He has two hands. Would it kill him to run a dust rag down one bench?

Lowell did not lift his head.

Gene. Come here.

What is it?

Go down and wash up. Then come back and sit by me.

Gene had used that voice on other people for thirty-one years, and he found that he obeyed it. He leaned the broom in the corner, went down to the basement sink and scrubbed to the elbows with the Lava, the way he had made twenty boys an hour do it, and came back up and sat down on the facing bench. He had never sat there. The room looked different from that end. He could see every place the varnish was going.

A man ought not to go about sweeping all the time, Lowell said. *Sweep first thing in the morning. Then go home and get thy breakfast. Then come back here, or stay home in thy chair, it is the same, and sit down, and look at thy hands a while. Thee has good hands. Consider what they are made of and how long they are good for. Toward evening get up and sweep again. But not the whole day, Gene. Leave thyself some room.*

The work doesn't do itself.

No, Lowell said, and seemed to give that its due. Then he said something Gene took for Bible, though it was not.

> *Give over thine own willing, give over thy own running, give over thine own desiring to know or to be any thing, and sink down to the Seed which God sows in the heart, and let that grow in thee, and be in thee.*
>
> *— Isaac Penington, Some Directions to the Panting Soul (1661)*

Who's that?

Isaac Penington. They had him in jail six times. I have wondered if that was what it took to get him to sit down.

III. Bill of Materials

Eleventh Month to Second Month

He did it the way he did everything, which was to the letter. He swept at seven. He went home and ate two eggs. At nine he came back and sat down on the third bench by the south window, where Marjorie had sat, and he stayed there until four with a half hour out for the sandwich in the truck. At four he swept again and went home.

The first week he looked at his hands and saw only what wanted doing with them. The storm windows were not up. A stair tread was working loose. He sat on the hands, literally, until they went to sleep.

Then he did what he knew how to do, and wrote up a bill of materials. He wrote it in his head, as for any project. Hair of the head. Hair of the body. Nails, teeth, skin. Meat, cords, bone, and what is inside the bone. Kidneys, heart, liver. He went down the list and back up it the way he had made boys check their stock against a cut list before they were let near a switch, and it came to thirty-two items when he had it grouped right, though he never wrote it down.

None of it was rated for anything. For thirty-one years he had read out to boys what a blade guard was rated for, and a chain, and a pair of safety glasses. Nobody had stamped a number on Marjorie's liver. He looked at the short finger, at the pad of skin the doctor in Iowa City had folded over the end and stitched down. It had been numb since 1971. That piece of him had already gone on ahead, and he had held it up in front of twenty-two sophomores to show them, and then had not looked at it again for twenty-seven years.

It was a Third Day in Second Month, a little after two. The furnace had cycled off. A boxelder bug was walking along the back of the bench in front of him, and he was partway down the list, at the lungs.

Something that had been running in him stopped.

He had not known it was running. It had run when he was a boy picking up cobs behind his father's wagon. It had run through thirty-one years of bells and through Marjorie's last winter. It had pushed a broom up and down the dining room under twenty people sitting in silence. It quit the way a compressor quits at the end of the day, and he heard how quiet the room was, and understood that the room had been that quiet the whole time.

He sat until four. At four he did not get up. Lowell, on the facing bench, raised his head and looked down the length of the room at him, and lowered it again.

IV. The Sills

Fifth Month 1999

By spring the meetinghouse was a sight. The orange lady beetles that had come into the state a few years before had wintered in the south wall and died on the windowsills in drifts. Boxelder bugs lay among them. The mud that came in on boots during the thaw had dried in the grain of the floor, a web ran from the clock to the stovepipe hole, and somebody found mouse sign in the cloakroom. Outside, the grass stood to the shin, and the dandelions bloomed and went to seed, which had not happened on that lot since 1994.

Gene was there every day. The truck pulled in at nine. He sat on the third bench by the south window with dead beetles along the sill at his elbow, and he looked like a man with nowhere else he needed to be.

Friends are slow to speak to another person's condition, and slower when that person has been doing their work for them. It was well into Fifth Month before Arlene Stanley and two others of the property committee, which had not met in five years, stopped him on the porch.

Gene, the house is full of dirt. There are bugs on every sill. Why doesn't thee sweep it?

I used to, he said. *That was back when I wasn't paying attention. I'm paying attention now.*

He held the door for them, and went in and sat down.

V. The Minute

Monthly meeting for business · Sixth Month

Arlene brought it to the meeting as a concern. She stood by her bench with her hand on the back of the one in front. She said that for three years this man had not sat down among them one First Day, and the meeting had let him, to its shame, because it liked the paint. Now he sat all day in a dirty house and told Friends he was paying attention. *He says one thing and does another,* she said, and sat.

Dale Hockett was clerk that year. He was fifty-three and sold crop insurance out of an office in Tipton, hail and multi-peril, and he had spent the past winter at kitchen tables with men whose hogs had brought under ten cents a pound. He had learned at those tables to let a thing be said all the way out before he put a hand to it. He let this one lie for some minutes. Gene sat on the third bench. Lowell sat on the facing bench with his eyes down. A beetle that had lived through the winter walked up the window glass behind them.

Friends, Dale said, *I believe Gene has told us the plain truth. When he was not paying attention he swept all day. I heard him under this floor every First Day for three years, and so did all of you. He is where he ought to be now, and so he doesn't.*

He waited again.

I was given a verse this morning on the road. I thought it was for me.

> *For ye were sometimes darkness, but now are ye light in the Lord: walk as children of light.*
>
> *— Ephesians 5:8*

Nobody spoke after it. When enough time had gone by, the recording clerk read back what she had written. Friends were in unity that Gene Aldinger had spoken truly. The property committee was asked to meet, and to find where the broom was kept. Friends approved the minute, and Arlene Stanley approved it first.

• • •

The committee found the broom on its nail in the furnace room, with a web from the ash handle to the wall. They found that the mower had been Gene's own, and that the meeting did not have one.

He drove home to Tipton that afternoon to the house on Meridian Street, where he had not cut the grass since Fourth Month and where the neighbors, who for five summers had been waked at seven, now had a different complaint. It had been overcast for three days. About ten that night the cloud came apart over the grain elevator, and the moon stood

clear of it. Gene was on the back step in his sock feet. Every dandelion on the lot had gone to seed, and they stood up out of the long grass by the hundred, each one round and white, lit.

Background

The verse

> *He who formerly was reckless and afterwards became sober, brightens up this world, like the moon when freed from clouds.*
>
> Dhammapada 172, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk called Sammuñjani, "Broom," sweeps the monastery morning and afternoon without regard for the hour. Finding the elder Revata sitting in his cell, he thinks him a great idler who lives on the gifts of the faithful and will not sweep so much as one room. Revata sends him to bathe, sits him down, and tells him to sweep early, go for alms, sit and contemplate the thirty-two parts of the body and its perishing, and sweep again at evening, leaving himself some leisure. The monk keeps to this exactly and soon becomes an arahant. Then the rooms fill with rubbish. Asked why he no longer sweeps, he says he did that when he was heedless and is heedful now. The monks report that he says one thing and does another, and the Buddha answers that he has spoken the truth. Read the full commentary story; the body contemplation Revata assigns is described under Paṭikūlamanasikāra.

Cedar County, Iowa

Conservative Friends in Iowa, 1998

Conservative Friends are the small branch of American Quakers who kept the old unprogrammed worship: no pastor, no hymns, a room of benches where people sit in silence until someone is moved to speak. Iowa Yearly Meeting (Conservative) has a

handful of rural and college-town meetings and owns Scattergood Friends School, founded in 1890 in Cedar County near West Branch, a town first settled by Quakers. Older Conservative Friends still said "thee" to one another in the 1990s and numbered the days and months instead of naming them. Business is done in a meeting for worship in which nobody votes; the clerk listens for the sense of the meeting and it is written down as a minute. Plum Run Meeting and its people are invented. Isaac Penington (1616–1679) was imprisoned six times beginning in 1661, the year he published the letter Lowell quotes.

The multicolored Asian lady beetle, *Harmonia axyridis*, was first found in Iowa in 1994 and within a few years was coming into buildings each fall to spend the winter in the walls. In December 1998 the price of hogs collapsed, and Iowa farmers were paid less than ten cents a pound for live animals, less in real terms than their grandfathers had been paid in the Depression.

After the story of the Elder Sammuñjani from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 172). The original. Scripture from Isaac Penington's Some Directions to the Panting Soul (1661) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

13.6

Stand Still

> *Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD.*
> *— Exodus 14:13*

So hab ich's gehört, on Big Creek.

I. The Burnt District

Cass County, Missouri · autumn 1864

After Order Number Eleven there was nobody left in the border counties but chimneys. The army had emptied Jackson and Cass and Bates in the summer of 1863, every family not able to swear its loyalty before a provost marshal, and then the Kansas men and the Missouri men took turns burning what was left. What stood afterward were the chimneys, stone and brick, one to a farm, rising out of the ash and the ragweed like gravestones for houses. People called them Jennison's monuments, after the Kansas colonel who had started it. You could ride a whole day and see nothing taller than a man except chimneys.

Gabriel Mantooth rode alone through that country in the fall of 1864, because by then even the bushwhackers would not ride with him.

He was twenty years old. He had been the best scholar at the academy in Lone Jack, could do sums in his head faster than the master could do them on the slate, could recite whole books of Milton. He had been at Lawrence with Quantrill, at nineteen, and come home with something gone out of his face. After Lawrence the others took scalps and tied them to their bridles. Gabriel took a finger. One from every man, the right forefinger, the trigger finger, and he dried them in salt and smoke and strung them on a rawhide thong he wore around his neck, under his coat,

where they clicked against each other when he rode like dry pods on a locust tree.

Nobody knew why fingers. Some said he was counting toward a number. Some said a number had been put in his head by somebody, and he was only paying it off. The people in the Burnt District called the thong his rosary, which was a joke, because there were not three Catholics in Cass County. They called him Beads. Mothers said it to children at night. *You go to sleep, or Beads will come.*

He had burned out more families than anybody could count, Union families and some Southern ones too when it suited him, and he had killed more men than there was room for on one thong. He had started a second.

II. The Road

The Harrisonville road · October 1864

Elder Jacob Ebersole of the German Baptist Brethren walked west on the Harrisonville road in the middle of a clear afternoon with nothing in his hands. He was sixty-three years old. He wore the plain coat with the standing collar and the broad black hat, and his beard went down his chest with no mustache above it, the way the Brethren wore them, because a mustache was a soldier's vanity and the Brethren did not go to war. They did not go to law and did not take oaths. They washed one another's feet at the love feast and dunked their converts three times forward in running water, which is why the world called them Dunkards, and they did not lift a hand against any living thing. Both armies thought they were cowards. Both armies had shot some of them for it.

A boy herding three cows in a burnt field ran to the fence and said, *Mister, don't go that way. Beads is on that road.* The Elder nodded to him and walked on.

A widow at a well by a chimney said, *He was by here two days ago. Mister, he'll kill you for your hat.* The Elder thanked her for the water and walked on.

A farmer leading a mule stopped dead in the road in front of him and took hold of his sleeve. *Old man. Old man. You don't know what's out there.* The Elder put his hand over the farmer's hand for a moment, and then gently took it off his sleeve, and walked on.

He did not say anything to any of them.

III. Stand Still

The same afternoon

Gabriel saw him from the bluff above Big Creek. One man, walking alone, in a black hat, on the open road through the burnt country, as if it were Sunday and the road went to church. Something about it made Gabriel angrier than he had been in a long time. He checked the loads in both Navy Colts and came down off the bluff at a gallop.

The old man was perhaps three hundred yards ahead.

Gabriel rode hard. The bay was the best horse in western Missouri and he had stolen it from a colonel. He leaned over its neck and gave it the spurs and the road went by under them like water, and the old man was walking, not hurrying, not looking back, an old man's walk, and he was three hundred yards ahead.

Gabriel rode until the bay was lathered white at the chest and blowing blood. The old man was three hundred yards ahead.

He got down and ran. He ran with the carbine in one hand until his lungs tore and his mouth tasted of iron and the thong of fingers rattled against his breastbone like something trying to get out. The old man was walking. He was three hundred yards ahead.

Gabriel stopped in the middle of the road with his hands on his knees and screamed it at him.

Stand still, old man! Stand still!

The Elder did not turn around. His voice came back down the road as easy as if he were standing right there, at Gabriel's elbow.

I am standing still, Gabriel Mantooth. You stand still.

You're walking. I can see you walking. What kind of a damned lie is that?

Then the Elder did stop, and turned, and he was not three hundred yards away at all. He was right there in the road, an arm's length off, an old man with dust on his boots and grey eyes.

I put it down, he said. *A long time ago. The gun and the stick and the fist, toward every living thing. Toward the Kansas men and the Missouri men and the mule and the cow and the dog and you. That's standing still. You haven't put it down toward anything. You've been running since Lawrence, son, and you can't catch anybody, because there's nobody out here to catch. It's just you.*

> *And they shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruninghooks: nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war any more.*
>
> *— Isaiah 2:4*

There was a sinkhole by the road, one of those places in that country where the ground has simply fallen in on itself, thirty feet deep, ferns at the bottom, cold air coming up. Gabriel walked to the edge of it and threw in the carbine. Then one Colt. Then the other. Then the knife. Then, after a long time standing there, he pulled the rawhide thong over his head and threw that in too.

The Elder came and stood next to him and looked down into the hole.

Not that, he said. *Those were men. Go down and get them.*

So Gabriel climbed down into the sinkhole and found the thong among the ferns in the cold, and climbed back up with it, and they walked to the Brethren meetinghouse on Big Creek together, and that night by lantern light under the cedar behind it, they buried what was on the thong. The Elder asked if he knew any of the names. Gabriel knew some. He said them, the ones he knew, one at a time, standing at the edge of the hole with his hat in his hands, and when he ran out of names he said *and a man by the ford on the Little Blue,* and *and a boy at Lawrence by the livery,* and *and,* and *and,* until the Elder put a hand on his back.

Three weeks later they took him down to Big Creek where it ran fast over the gravel and the Elder dunked him three times forward, in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost, and he came up

out of the cold water the third time with his mouth open like a newborn, and the Elder said, *Come, brother.*

IV. The Colonel

Big Creek meetinghouse · April 1865

Colonel Abner Pryce of the Missouri State Militia came in the spring with forty men and a rope. There were petitions from three counties. There were widows who had walked to Kansas City to see him. He rode into the meetinghouse yard with his pistol already out and found an old man in a plain coat sitting on a bench in the sun, mending a harness.

Colonel, said the Elder, *is it Shelby again? Is it the guerrillas troubling you?*

It's one guerrilla. It's Beads. I'm told you're hiding him.

I'm not hiding anybody, said the Elder, and pointed with his awl. *That's him there, splitting kindling.*

Colonel Pryce had been at Westport and Lone Jack and had never in his life been as frightened as he was looking at the young man by the woodpile in shirtsleeves, with his hair cut short and his beard coming in with no mustache. The pistol shook in his hand. Forty men behind him sat their horses and did not breathe.

You can put that up, the Elder said. *There's no need.*

The Colonel did not put it up. But after a while he asked, because it was the only thing he could think to ask, *Who are your people?*

Gabriel set down the hatchet. *George Mantooth and Mary Mantooth. Of Lone Jack.*

The Colonel was quiet for a moment. *I knew your father,* he said. *He sold me a horse in fifty-five and told me everything that was wrong with it before he told me the price.* He put the pistol back in its holster. *Do you want for anything? I could see you get a coat, provisions. I could see about a paper.*

I've got a coat, said Gabriel. *And a shirt, and another shirt. That's enough.*

The Colonel turned his horse. At the gate of the yard he stopped and looked back at the old man on the bench.

I brought forty men, he said, *and I don't believe I could have taken him. You took him with nothing in your hands.*

V. Born Again

Near Pleasant Hill · summer 1866

Gabriel walked to Pleasant Hill twice a week for meal and salt for the brethren. On the road back one evening in July he heard a woman screaming in a cabin built up against a standing chimney, a lean-to of new boards against old brick, and he knew without asking that she had been at it a long time. A girl of ten was sitting on the step with her hands over her ears.

He stood in the road a long time. *Lord,* he thought, *how every living thing suffers.* Then he went back to the meetinghouse at a run and found the Elder.

Go back to her, said the Elder. *Stand at the door and say: since the day I was born, I have never knowingly taken a life. By that truth, may you be well, and your child.*

Gabriel stared at him. *That's a lie. You know it's a lie. You were there under the cedar.*

Then say it right, said the Elder. *Since the day you were born again.*

> *Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.*
>
> *— John 3:3*

So he went back. The midwife from Pleasant Hill met him at the door with blood to her elbows, and maybe she knew his face and maybe she didn't, but nothing else had worked and she stood aside. He did not go in. He stood in the doorway with his hat in his hands and said it into the dark of the room.

Ma'am. Since the day I was born again, I have not knowingly taken any life. By that truth, may you be well, and your child.

The child came within the hour, a boy, and lived, and the woman lived. He heard about it two days later. Her husband had been killed in the summer of 1863, on the Lone Jack road, by men nobody ever named. Gabriel did not ask which men. He thought he knew. He went over the next week and put a proper roof on the lean-to and did not tell her who he was, and she did not ask, though she watched him the whole time from the step with the baby in her arms.

VI. Stones

Harrisonville · court day, 1867

It was a boy who knew him first, in the square on court day, a boy of fourteen or so, who shouted it. Then a man. Then the square. They threw clods first, and then sticks, and then a man picked up a cobble from the edge of the street and threw that, and then everybody did.

Gabriel did not run. He did not lift his arms. He walked out of Harrisonville in the middle of the road with the meal sack torn open and spilling behind him like a trail, and his scalp opened over the left ear, and blood running down into his collar, and they followed him to the edge of town throwing.

He walked the eleven miles back to Big Creek. The Elder washed the cut at the pump and sewed it with a harness needle and Gabriel did not make a sound.

Bear it, Gabriel, the Elder said. *Bear it. You're paying a little now on a debt you'd have been a long, long time paying otherwise.*

I know it, said Gabriel. *I know it.*

> *Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap.*
>
> *— Galatians 6:7*

VII. The Moon

Big Creek · 1867–1870

He lived alone after that, in a cabin on the creek, and he went out working. He did not go to the people who had not been hurt. He went to the chimneys.

Families were coming back to the Burnt District by then, a few at a time, after the war. They came home to a chimney in the ragweed and nothing else, and somewhere around the second week, a young man with no mustache and a scar over his left ear would come walking up the road with an axe and a froe and a crosscut saw on his back, and start cutting logs, and not leave until there was a house around the chimney again. Some of them knew who he was. Some of them ran him off. Some of them ran him off and he came back the next morning and started again, and eventually they let him. He built eleven houses in three years around eleven chimneys. On some of them he did not let himself sleep under the roof he had made, but walked home to the creek in the dark.

He died in the winter of 1870 of a fever that went through the county, in his own bed, with the Elder sitting beside him. He was twenty-six. The last thing he said was something nobody could make out, a name, or the beginning of one.

At the love feast that spring the brethren talked about it after the feet-washing, quietly, over the bread and the beef and the cup. Where had he gone? They had all forgiven him; that was the easy part, that was what they were for. But where had he gone? A man like that. All those men under the cedar.

The Elder had been listening. He set down the cup.

My son has gone home, he said.

Someone said, gently, *Elder. Beads?*

He had nobody to tell him, said the Elder. *For twenty years nobody told him anything that was true. Then he had somebody, and he listened, and he never once stopped listening. That's all. That's the whole of it.*

> *And above all things have fervent charity among yourselves: for charity shall cover the multitude of sins.*
>
> *— 1 Peter 4:8*

That night the sky over the Burnt District was full of low cloud running east, the kind that comes before a change in the weather. The Elder walked home along Big Creek in the dark, past the cabin, and stopped on the rise where you could see the country to the west. There were lights in it now. Not many. Eleven of them, maybe, if you knew where to look, each one a window in a house built up around an old chimney, each chimney with smoke going up out of it into the dark.

Then the cloud tore open, and the moon came out from behind it, full and white, and lit the whole country, every field and every road and every chimney, all the way to Kansas, as if there had never been a cloud at all.

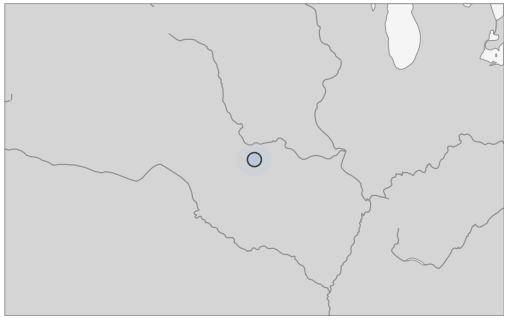
> *Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like crimson, they shall be as wool.*
>
> *— Isaiah 1:18*

Background

The verse

> *He whose evil deeds are covered by good deeds, brightens up this world, like the moon when freed from clouds.*
>
> Dhammapada 173, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Aṅgulimāla ("finger-garland") was a robber who killed travelers and wore their fingers around his neck. When he chased the Buddha, running as hard as he could, he could not catch a man who was only walking. "I have stopped, Aṅgulimāla," the Buddha told him. "You stop." He threw his weapons into a pit, became a monk, healed a woman in childbirth by an act of truth, and endured being stoned in the streets. Read the full commentary story, or about Aṅgulimāla.



The Burnt District, Missouri

The Missouri border, 1863–1870

The Kansas-Missouri border had been at war with itself since the 1850s. During the Civil War, pro-Confederate bushwhackers fought Union troops and Kansas "jayhawkers" in a guerrilla war of ambush, house-burning and murder. Some of the guerrillas, notably Bloody Bill Anderson's men, took scalps. On August 21, 1863, William Quantrill's raiders sacked Lawrence, Kansas, and killed more than 150 men and boys. Four days later, General Thomas Ewing issued General Order No. 11, expelling most rural residents of Jackson, Cass and Bates counties and part of Vernon. The emptied country was burned, and for years it was called the Burnt District. The chimneys left standing were known as "Jennison's monuments," after the jayhawker Charles Jennison.

The German Baptist Brethren, called Dunkers or Dunkards, began in Germany in 1708 and came to Pennsylvania in the 1720s. They baptized by immersing believers three times forward, held a love feast with feetwashing, refused oaths, and practiced nonresistance. In the Civil War they would not bear arms for either side, which made them suspect to both.

After the story of the Elder Aṅgulimāla from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 173). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

13.7

The Quills

For man also knoweth not his time.
— Ecclesiastes 9:12

Azoy hob ikh gehert, on the Golden Stairs.

I. The Snake and the Stick

Paterson, New Jersey · February 1921

That winter the mills were dark. After the war the silk trade had fallen down a well, and in Paterson the looms stood under dust sheets for eight and nine and ten months together, and the weavers who had come from Białystok and Łódź to escape the old country's hunger walked the cobbles of Temple Street with their hands in their pockets and their bellies talking. When a mill did take people back, it took them back at sixty cents on the dollar. Everybody said it. Sixty cents on the dollar, and be grateful.

In February Rivke Shapiro died. She was twenty-four and a broad-silk weaver at one of the big mills on the river, a good one, and she had the cough two years, and the Workmen's Circle sent her to its sanatorium in the mountains at Liberty, nine months free, and she came home looking better, and then she had it in the blood, and then she was a weight under a sheet in her mother's front room on the hill. It was the weavers' sickness. Everybody had somebody. The lint got into you and the damp of the weave rooms got into you, and the doctors said tuberculosis and the weavers said *di shvindzukht*, the wasting, and buried their girls.

The Workmen's Circle held a memorial meeting for her in its rooms on the second floor over a harness shop, and because the Shapiros were Bundists from way back, and because there was no rabbi any of them

would have let near a coffin, they sent to New York for Dvoyre Mazur to speak.

Bashe Reznik went with her father. She was sixteen. She had been a winder in the same mill until the shutdown, filling quills for the weavers from the big bobbins of raw silk, and she had sat beside Rivke Shapiro at lunch for a year and been given half her apples. She sat on a folding chair at the end of a row in a hall that smelled of wet wool and coal smoke and herring, and when the old woman came to the front she did not look like much. She was short and broad and wore a man's overcoat over a black dress, and her hair was white and cut like a boy's, and she put both her hands on the back of a chair and leaned on it as if it were a cart she was pushing uphill.

Everybody in the room knew her story, or a piece of it. A Bundist in Białystok from before anybody there was born. Arrested in 1906 with a bag of pamphlets and a revolver she swore she had never fired. Sentenced to hang. Five months in a cell in the Warsaw Citadel waiting for the morning they would come for her, and then the sentence changed to Siberia, and she walked out of Siberia, people said, the long way, across Manchuria to the sea. Now she taught Yiddish to children in the Workmen's Circle schools in the Bronx and on the East Side, and believed in nothing that anyone could put in a prayer book. People said she had once thrown a Hasid out of a lecture hall with her own two hands.

She did not talk about Rivke Shapiro's politics, or about the bosses, or the cough, though everybody expected her to. She talked about the Citadel.

For five months, she said, *every morning at four o'clock, I heard the boots in the corridor. Sometimes they went past my door. Sometimes they stopped at a door near mine. I learned the sound of a man who was ready and the sound of a man who was not. The ones who were not ready screamed. Big men, brave men, men who had thrown bombs. They screamed like a man who comes on a snake in the road with nothing in his hands.*

There was a shoemaker in the cell next to mine, a boy from Grodno. Every night he knocked on the wall to me in the prisoners' code, the same thing every night. I will die. I do not know when. I will die. When they came for him he went

the way a man goes who sees a snake in the path a long way off, and has a stick in his hand, and puts the snake off the path with the stick, and goes on walking. I heard him go. He said good morning to the guards.

She was quiet a while.

Nobody here is going to hang. But everyone in this room is going to die, and does not know when. Rivke did not know. So this is what I tell my pupils, and I will tell you. Every night, before you sleep, say it. My life is not certain. My death is certain. I will die. I do not know when. Not to frighten yourselves. You are frightened enough. To have a stick in your hand.

Then she sat down. There was some coughing. Somebody started the *Shvue*, the Bund's oath song, and they all stood and sang it, and then they went down the stairs into the snow and talked about whether the big mills would open in March, and whether it would be three looms to a weaver or four, and whether you could get a job in Passaic.

Bashe Reznik walked home behind her father up the Golden Stairs, the long wooden staircase that climbed the hill above the mills. She counted the steps. At the top she said it to herself for the first time. *My life is not certain. My death is certain.* She did not stop saying it for three years.

II. Quills

The Reznik shop, Van Houten Street · 1921–1924

Her mother was already dead. The influenza had taken her in the fall of 1918, in nine days, and Bashe and her father had lived since then in two rooms on the hill, with her mother's sewing machine under a cloth in the corner because neither of them could stand to sell it or to use it.

Hershl Reznik was a weaver the way some men are tall. He had been a weaver in Białystok, and his father before him, and his grandfather on the hand looms in the cottages before there were mills, and he had the soft clean hands of the trade and its bad back and its habit of sleeping all Saturday afternoon like a dead man. In 1922, when the mills began to call people back, he did not go back. He took the money he and his wife had put by for Bashe's wedding and bought two old Crompton looms from a

shop that was closing, and rented a corner of the top floor of a brick mill by the raceway, with power off the shaft, and set up for himself. It was done all over Paterson in those years. A man with two looms and a commission from a converter in New York could weave by himself for himself and be nobody's four-loom slave, if he did not mind working until midnight. Hershl did not mind. He worked until midnight and later. He was saving for the wedding money again.

Bashe wound his quills. She sat on a stool by the window at the end of the shop with the winding frame, and the raw silk came off the big bobbins in a fine yellow thread, finer than hair, and went onto the little wooden quills that fit inside the shuttles, layer on layer, until each quill was fat and gold and shining. She filled a box of them every afternoon, a hundred or so, and carried them down the aisle to her father's looms, and he took them out one at a time all evening, slid each into its shuttle, drew the end of the thread through the eye with his shuttle hook, and sent the shuttle flying.

The room was a pounding. Thirty or forty looms on that floor in a dozen little shops like theirs, the shafts rising and falling, the leather belts slapping on the pulleys, the lays banging forward and back, and the shuttles going across the warps so fast you could not see them, only a dart of light and a crack at either end. Children were warned. Everybody knew of somebody who had been hit by a shuttle that jumped the shed. Hershl wore his eyeglasses down on his nose and pushed them up with the back of his wrist.

Every quill, Bashe said it. It took about a minute to fill a quill. *My life is not certain.* The thread going on, gold. *My death is certain.* The thread going on. *I will die.* Snap it off, set the full one in the box, take an empty one. *I do not know when.* A hundred times an afternoon. Then at night on her cot, with the window open a crack for the air, as the old woman had said.

She did not tell her father. She did not tell anybody. At first it was like a stone she carried in her chest. Then for a long time it was like nothing; it was like the pounding of the looms, which you stop hearing in a week. Then, sometime in the second year, she found that she was not afraid of things. She was not afraid of the foreman at the dye house who had put

his hand on her at the Christmas party. She was not afraid of the man from the converter in New York who came to cheat her father on the yardage and went away cheated himself because she had kept the count. When her father had pleurisy in the second winter she sat up with him five nights with the cold rag and the mustard plaster and was not afraid of that either, and he got well. She found she was not afraid of being an old maid, or of not being one. Things in the street looked very clear to her, as if somebody had washed the windows of the town.

Nobody else in Paterson remembered what Dvoyre Mazur had said at Rivke Shapiro's memorial. Bashe asked a few of them, carefully, and they remembered the old woman, and her haircut, and the Citadel, and that she had been very good; they could not remember what about.

III. The Hall

The Workmen's Circle rooms · a Thursday in April 1924

THE NOTICE WAS ON THE BOARD AT THE COOPERATIVE BAKERY on Tyler Street. Comrade Dvoyre Mazur of New York would speak on Thursday evening at eight on the subject of I. L. Peretz and the Jewish worker. Bashe read it with a loaf of rye under her arm and felt her heart turn over, the way it had not turned over in three years about anything.

On Thursday her father had a warp to finish. A converter wanted forty yards of a yellow crepe by Friday noon, and it was eleven yards short. He came home at six to eat and said it at the table without looking up from his soup.

Bashele, I need quills tonight. The whole box. I'm out by nine o'clock.

Tate, Dvoyre Mazur is speaking tonight. At eight.

So go after. He looked at her. He was not a hard man; he was a tired one. *I'll be there until two in the morning if I don't have quills. You want to go to a lecture, go, but bring me the quills first.*

She sat with that a minute. Then she put on her coat and went down to the shop instead of to the hall, and sat at the winding frame under the bare electric bulb, and filled a hundred quills of yellow silk as fast as she

had ever done it in her life, saying it on every one, and it was after eight-thirty when she put the box under her arm and ran.

• • •

The hall was full. They had put out every folding chair in the building and men stood along the walls. Dvoyre Mazur had come in at eight, and taken off the man's overcoat, and put her hands on the back of the chair, and looked out over the room for a long time.

Then she sat down in the chair and said nothing.

It went on. A minute. Five. The chairman of the branch, a presser named Gurevitsh, leaned over and asked her quietly if she was well. She said she was perfectly well. She had come twenty miles, she said, from the Bronx, on the subway and a ferry and the Erie, for the sake of one person in this room, and that person was not here yet, and she would wait. Then she folded her hands and waited, and the hall, after some shifting and muttering and a man in the back saying loudly that he had paid a nickel, went quiet, because people who had not been afraid of the police in 1913 were somehow afraid of that small old woman sitting still.

That was how it was when Bashe came up the stairs. A hall full of people sitting in silence and looking at the front.

She stopped at the back, inside the door, with the box of quills under her arm and silk lint on her sleeves and her face red from running. She meant only to look. Her father was waiting.

Dvoyre Mazur lifted her head and looked down the length of the room at her, past all those heads, and Bashe understood that look the way you understand someone calling your name. She set the box of quills on the floor by the door and walked up the aisle between the chairs, and the people turned and watched her go, and she came and stood beside the old woman's chair.

IV. Four Questions

The same evening

The old woman did not get up. She spoke to her in Yiddish, quietly, the way you speak to someone across a kitchen table, but in that silence the whole room heard it.

Bashe Reznik. Where do you come from?

I don't know, Dvoyre.

Where are you going?

I don't know.

You don't know?

I know.

You know?

I don't know.

The hall did not like it. A man laughed out loud. Somebody said, not quietly, that Hershl Reznik's girl had a mouth on her, to make fun of an old revolutionary to her face. A woman in the third row said that if the girl came from the Reznik shop she should say so, she had silk all over her, everybody could see where she came from, and where she was going was back to her father, so why the riddles? Somebody else said it was the kind of thing you heard from a *rebbe*'s daughter, mysticism, superstition, and they had not come out on a Thursday night to hear superstition. Gurevitsh the chairman stood up to say something and the old woman put a hand on his sleeve and he sat down.

Bashe. When I asked where you come from, why did you say you don't know?

You know I came from my father's shop on Van Houten Street, Bashe said. *Everybody can see. You weren't asking that. You were asking where I was before I was born. That I don't know.*

Good, said Dvoyre Mazur. *And where you are going?*

I'm going back to the shop with the quills. You weren't asking that either. You were asking where I go after I die. I don't know.

Good. And when I said you don't know, why did you say you know?

Because I know I'm going to die.

And when I said you know?

I know I'm going to die. I don't know when. Tonight or in the morning or when I'm an old woman. That I don't know.

The old woman nodded four times, slowly, once for each answer. Then she turned in her chair to face the room.

You laughed at her. All of you. A hall full of freethinkers. You read the papers, you read Marx, you read Peretz, you can tell me the price of raw silk in Yokohama. And this child is the only one here who answered me honestly.

When I was a girl my father made me learn the Sayings of the Fathers by heart, a chapter every Sabbath afternoon in the summer. I threw out the rest of what he taught me a long time ago. This one I kept, because it is a good question, even if the old men had their answers ready before they asked it.

> *Consider three things, and thou wilt not come within the power of sin: know whence thou camest, and whither thou art going, and before whom thou wilt in the future have to give an account and reckoning.*
>
> *— Pirke Avot 3:1*

The rabbis knew where you came from and where you were going. They had it written down. I don't know. This girl doesn't know. She is not ashamed to say so, and she knows the one thing that is certain, and she knows that it is not certain when. You think she was talking in riddles. You are the ones who can't see. Most people can't see. I have known that since the Citadel.

Then she said a thing in Hebrew, which surprised the room more than anything else she had done that night, and then said it again in Yiddish, and the older people who had been to *kheyder* as boys in Białystok knew where it came from, one from Koheleth and one from the Psalms, and some of them had not heard either one since their own fathers' funerals.

For man also knoweth not his time; as the fishes that are taken in an evil net, and as the birds that are caught in the snare, even so are the sons of men snared in an evil time, when it falleth suddenly upon them.

— Ecclesiastes 9:12

Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers; the snare is broken, and we are escaped.

— Psalm 124:7

Bashe stood beside the chair and heard it, and something in her that had been pulled tight for three years, so tight she had forgotten it was a thing that could be loosened, gave way. It did not break. It was like a thread going slack when the shuttle stops. She saw the hall all at once, every face, the laughing man and the woman in the third row and Gurevitsh with his hands on his knees and the bare bulbs and the coats on the hooks and the windows black with April, and all of it was going to die, and none of it knew when, and she was not afraid for any of it, and she loved it. It was the simplest thing she had ever seen. She did not know how she had not seen it before.

Dvoyre Mazur looked up at her and saw her see it. She took Bashe's hand in both of hers, the old dry hands of a woman who had been in prison, and held it a moment, and let it go.

Go on, she said. *Your father is waiting for the quills.*

Then she stood up and put both hands on the back of the chair and talked for an hour and a half about I. L. Peretz and the Jewish worker, and it was very good, and afterward nobody could remember what about.

V. The Shuttle

The mill by the raceway · near ten o'clock

THE BUILDING WAS DARK EXCEPT FOR THE TOP FLOOR, WHERE two or three of the little shops were still running, and the stairwell shook with them. Bashe went up with the box under her arm. She was not tired. She felt as if she could have climbed the stairs to the roof and stepped off

AND WALKED ACROSS THE AIR OVER THE RACEWAY AND THE Falls and the whole of Paterson.

Her father had run out of quills. He had stopped his looms and was sitting on his box between them with his back against the post, and he was asleep. His chin was on his chest and his glasses were in his lap and his mouth was open a little, and his hand was still resting on the shipper handle of the near loom, the iron lever that throws the belt over and sets the loom running. A shuttle with an empty quill lay in the shuttle box where he had dropped it, not seated right.

She did not want to wake him. She came very quietly down the aisle and set the box of quills on the breastbeam of the loom, by his hand, so it would be the first thing he saw.

The breastbeam is a smooth, rounded bar of maple, polished by a thousand weavers' aprons. The box slid. It went off the far side and hit the floor and burst, and a hundred quills of yellow silk went rolling and clattering across the boards in every direction, and Hershl Reznik came awake all at once the way a man wakes in a pounding shop when the pounding stops, and did what his hand had done ten thousand times. He threw the handle.

The loom banged on. The lay came forward. The shuttle, which was not seated, jumped the shed.

It went out of the loom the way they do, faster than anything can be seen, a dart of light, a crack, a steel-tipped piece of hardwood the length of a man's forearm. It struck Bashe in the temple and she went down among the quills.

Hershl threw off the loom. He was on his knees on the floor with her head in his lap before it had stopped. A weaver from the next shop came running, and then another, and one of them ran down the four flights for a doctor, and it did not matter. She did not open her eyes. There was not much blood. The man from the next shop said afterward that he had seen a good many people hurt in mills, and he had never seen a face like that one on any of them. Not frightened. A little surprised, maybe, and then not even that. He said it was like somebody who has seen a snake a long way off in the path, and knows what it is.

The quills lay all over the floor, yellow, under the looms and against the walls, some of them still rolling a little on the boards.

VI. All the Rivers

East Broadway, New York · May 1924

They buried her in the Workmen's Circle ground, next to her mother, and there was a rabbi after all, because Hershl at the last minute wanted one, and the Bundists stood at the back with their hats on and did not say anything about it. Hershl tore his lapel. He sat the seven days on a low box in the two rooms on the hill with the mirror covered and the sewing machine in the corner, and people came up the Golden Stairs with food and went down again, and he did not speak.

On the eighth day he got up and put on his coat and took the Erie to Jersey City and the ferry across and the elevated down to East Broadway, where somebody had told him Dvoyre Mazur had a room over a printer's. He climbed the stairs. She opened the door and looked at him and stood aside to let him in.

You filled her head with death, he said, *and then death came.* He said it standing in the middle of her room, with his hat on. *Three years. Every night. I heard her through the wall, I thought she was praying, I thought, so let her pray, it doesn't hurt anybody. You came for her. You said so. Everybody in Paterson heard you say so. You came twenty miles for her and she came to you and then she went back to me and I killed her with my own hand.*

The old woman did not defend herself. She took his hat off for him and put it on the table and sat him down in her one chair and sat on the edge of the bed across from him, so that their knees were nearly touching, and let him weep. It went on a long time. When it slowed she gave him her handkerchief, and it was not very clean, and he used it.

Hershl, she said. *How many have you buried?*

He did not understand.

Your father. Your mother. Your brother in the pogrom in 1906. Your wife. Your daughter. Who else? Children? There were children before Bashe, I think.

There had been two. Both in Białystok, both before they were a year old.

And your father, how many did he bury? And his father? And theirs? Every one of them sat on the box with his coat torn, like you. Every one cried like you are crying. If you put it all together, Hershl, all the crying of all the Rezniks for all the Rezniks, back as far as there were Rezniks, it would go over the Falls in Paterson for a year. It would go over them for a hundred years. And it doesn't fill anything.

> *All the rivers run into the sea, yet the sea is not full; unto the place whither the rivers go, thither they go again.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 1:7*

I didn't come for her because she was going to die, Dvoyre said. *She was going to die. Everybody is. I came because she was ready to see, and she saw. I watched her see it. She walked out of that hall with a stick in her hand.* The old woman looked at him a long time. *You have none. You never had one. Neither did I, until the Citadel. Stay a while. Sit.*

He stayed the night in the chair. In the morning she made tea and they drank it at the window over East Broadway, and he did not go back to Paterson for a month.

• • •

He sold the two Crompton looms that summer, to a man from Haledon, for less than he had paid. He did not go back to the mills. In the fall the Workmen's Circle school in Paterson needed a man to keep the stove and sweep the rooms and walk the little ones home down the Golden Stairs in the dark, and he did that, and then he was helping with the lessons, and then by the end of the decade he was teaching the older children their Yiddish himself, Peretz and Sholem Aleichem and Morris Rosenfeld's sweatshop poems, a weaver with soft hands and his glasses down his nose. The children were a little afraid of him and liked him very much. He was a man, they said afterward, grown up, who never seemed to be in a hurry, and never seemed to be afraid of anything, and every year on the

first day of school he went down the rows and asked each of them the same thing, and waited for them to answer. *Where do you come from?*

On Sunday mornings in the summer he got up in the dark the way weavers do and climbed to the Heights above the Great Falls to see the sun come up over the town. He took one quill with him, a little wooden quill with yellow silk on it, wound fat and even, the last of a hundred. He found it under the loom the week he sold them. He sat in the grass at the top of the gorge with the quill in his hand and watched the Passaic come over the edge, brown and white and roaring, the whole river, all of it going over and none of it ever the same water twice, and the sun came up and found the silk, and it shone.

Background

The verse

> *This world is dark, few only can see here; a few only go to heaven, like birds escaped from the net.*
>
> Dhammapada 174, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha tells the people of Āḷavi to practice mindfulness of death: one who has done it meets death like a man who flicks a snake away with a stick, while one who has not screams like a man caught empty-handed. Everyone goes back to their business except a weaver's daughter of sixteen, who practices it for three years. The Buddha returns for her sake and sits in silence until she comes, though she is late because her father has asked her to fill his shuttle. He asks her where she comes from, where she is going, whether she knows, and whether she does not know. Her answers (I don't know, I don't know, I know, I don't know) offend the crowd until she explains them: she does not know where she came from before birth or where she will go after death; she knows she will die, but not when. He speaks the verse and she enters the stream. Going on to her father's workshop, she startles him awake; he jerks the loom, and its end strikes and kills her. When the grieving father comes to the Buddha, he is told he has wept more tears over the dead than there is water in the four oceans, and he becomes a monk. Read the full commentary story.

Paterson, New Jersey

Paterson, 1921–1924

Paterson, New Jersey, built on the water power of the Great Falls of the Passaic, was America's Silk City. After 1900 skilled Jewish textile workers came there from Łódź and Białystok, and by 1913 close to five thousand Jewish men and women worked in its silk mills, most of them as broad-silk weavers. In the 1913 strike they walked out with Italian, German and other weavers against the three- and four-loom system; in 1917 Jewish workers founded a cooperative bakery on Tyler Street. After the First World War the silk trade collapsed, mills closed for months at a time and wages were cut by more than forty percent. In August 1924 the broad-silk weavers struck again against the spread of three and four looms to a weaver. Tuberculosis was the trade's great killer; a labor magazine in 1924 counted it behind nearly two in five deaths among women in silk work.

Many of the Jewish weavers had been members of the Bund, the Jewish socialist party of the Russian Empire, whose members filled the tsarist prisons after 1905, among them the Tenth Pavilion of the Warsaw Citadel. In June 1906 a pogrom in Białystok killed scores of Jews. In America former Bundists built the Workmen's Circle, a mutual-aid order that paid for burials, ran a tuberculosis sanatorium at Liberty, New York, and from 1918 opened secular Yiddish schools for children. Dvoyre Mazur's text, from the Sayings of the Fathers, is quoted in Joseph I. Gorfinkle's 1913 translation. The Reznik family, Dvoyre Mazur and the Paterson hall are fictional.

After the story of the weaver's daughter from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 174). The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society translation (1917) and the Sayings of the Fathers, tr. Joseph I. Gorfinkle (1913). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

13.8

By What Road

> *Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers: the snare is broken, and we are escaped.*
> *— Psalm 124:7*

As it has been handed down, in Little Creek Hundred.

I. Thirty

Little Creek Hundred, Kent County, Delaware · Third Month 1855

They came up out of the marsh on the fourteenth of Third Month, a little before light, thirty of them in a single line. They had left three farms below the Choptank on a Saturday night and had been five nights walking. By day they had lain up in pine woods, and once in a tobacco barn. The oldest was a woman past sixty named Sabra, who had a stick she had cut on the road. The youngest was at the breast. Eleven of the children could walk and four had to be carried. A man named Ennals had brought them across the last of it in the dark by the muskrat leads, in water to the knee, each one holding the coat of the one ahead.

Abram Gibbs was standing at the edge of the hard ground when they came to it. Nobody had sent him word. He had a lantern with three sides shut.

Abram was a free man and had been born one. He was fifty or near it. He owned six acres of fast land and a right to the marsh in front of it, and the marsh was his living. He took muskrat from the first frost to the middle of March and cut salt hay in summer, and through the cold months he gunned wildfowl for the Philadelphia market. He sat in a class at the African Methodist meeting and was nobody's preacher. He did not say a great deal at any time. But for twenty years in that Hundred, when

people came up from the south, they were brought to Abram before they were taken on. The Friends who did the taking on never asked what he said to them. They knew only that people who had sat an hour with Abram Gibbs rode differently in the wagon afterward.

His own house would not hold thirty. He put them in Joseph Lindley's corn house, a quarter mile up the lane.

The Lindleys were Friends, of Little Creek Meeting. Joseph Lindley had a hay wagon with a false floor that would hide six grown people lying flat, or eight if some were small. It had never been asked to do more. He stood in his kitchen that morning working the sum. Thirty was four nights' hauling to the next house, twelve miles and back, with one wagon passing one tavern four nights running. There were men from Dorchester in Dover already with a printed bill. A Friend caught at this work could lose his farm, and one in the county above had lost his seven years before. A free colored man could be put on the block and sold, and that had been done too.

We'll begin tonight with the smallest, Joseph said. *Amos will drive.*

Amos was seventeen.

II. The Gate

The corn house lot · the same day, toward evening

He brought the wagon down the lane as the light was going and stopped at the gate of the lot. The corn house door stood open. He could see them inside, sitting close together on the floor, and Abram in front of them on an upturned bushel with his hat on his knee.

Abram was asking them their names. He went to each one, the babies as well, and asked, and waited for it, and said it back.

Amos had been raised not to break in on a thing like that. He thought he would wait until Abram had done greeting them, and speak to him then about the wagon. He looped the lines over the post and stood by the gate.

After the names there was talk. He could not make it out. Abram's voice was low and did not rise. Once all of them laughed together,

quietly, thirty people at once, and he had not expected to hear that from the building. Then it was still. The mare shifted her feet. A rail called out on the marsh. He waited what he judged to be a quarter of an hour more. Then, since it was coming on dark and there were twelve miles to go, he went up to the door.

Abram was sitting on the bushel alone. Thirty of Hannah Lindley's quilts were folded and stacked against the wall with the corners squared. There was no one else in the corn house.

Abram, thirty came. Where are they?

Gone.

Amos looked behind him. There was the one lane, and he had been standing in it. On the other three sides lay the marsh with the tide out, and the mud ran smooth and shining all the way to the creek. A heron could not have crossed it without leaving a track.

By what road?

Through the air.

The boy turned that over. He had been taught to look for the plain sense of whatever was said to him, and he could find only the one.

But are they free, then? It is sixty miles to the Pennsylvania line, and Canada beyond it.

They're free. They heard what I had to tell them, and they were free before they got up off that floor. After that the going was no trouble.

It was the season for it. All that week the geese had been getting up off the bay and leaving. A long line of them came in now over the marsh, so low that Amos heard the wings creak before he heard the voices. They passed over the corn house roof and bore away north where the sky was already dark. Abram came to the door to watch. He had shot geese for thirty winters and sold them by the pair, and he stood with his hat in his hand until the last one was over.

There, he said. *Those have a road up there. Nobody cut it for them. The ones that were in here went the same.*

He had the verse by heart, from class.

> *Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers: the snare is broken, and we are escaped.*
>
> *— Psalm 124:7*

I'm a fowler, Abram said. *I know what a snare is. Take your mother her quilts.*

III. The Daybook

Little Creek Hundred · Third Month to Sixth Month

The men from Dorchester came at sunup with a constable out of Dover and two dogs. They had a paper. Joseph Lindley read it through and told them they might look where they liked. The dogs took the scent down the lane with a great noise and into the corn house. There they went once around the floor and lay down. No scent went out of it. The men walked the edge of the marsh for an hour, and one went in to his thighs and had to be hauled. At the last they looked up, as men will when there is nowhere else to look. The sky was empty. They went back to Dover.

In Sixth Month a letter came for Abram Gibbs by way of Philadelphia, from St. Catharines in Canada West. Abram could read print and could not read script, and he carried it up the lane to Amos. It was written in a schoolmaster's hand. It gave thirty names, the grown people first and then the children down to the youngest, in the order Abram had asked them. A few had signed and the rest had made their marks. It said they were all well and had found work, and that old Sabra wished him told she had the stick yet. It said they had come in on the morning of the fifteenth of March.

Amos read the date over twice. That was the morning the dogs lay down.

Abram took his letter home. He trapped that marsh nineteen years more. It was noticed in the Hundred that he sent no geese to market that spring, or any spring after it. He went on sending ducks. When he was asked, he said he had no quarrel with a duck.

Friends are not people who keep legends, and Little Creek Meeting never set this down in any minute. But Joseph Lindley kept a daybook for the farm, where he entered wages and weather and what was sown, and he could not leave a day unentered. The book is in the family yet. The line for that day is in his hand, and under it, as on every other page, he has ruled across and put down the wind.

3d mo. 14th. Thirty persons lodged in the corn house. Departed at evening. By what road not known.

Wind southerly. Fair.

Background

The verse

> *The swans go on the path of the sun, they go through the ether by means of their miraculous power; the wise are led out of this world, when they have conquered Mara and his train.*
>
> Dhammapada 175, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Thirty monks from a distant country came to see the Buddha at Jetavana. Ānanda, arriving to wait on him, saw them going in and decided to stay at the gate until the greetings were over. The Buddha greeted them and taught them, and all thirty became arahats, rose into the air and left. When they did not come out, Ānanda went in and asked where they were. "Gone." "By what path?" "Through the air." "Have they already rid themselves of the pollutants?" "Yes." Just then a flock of geese flew over, and the Buddha said that one who has developed the bases of power goes through the sky like those, and spoke the verse. That is the whole of the full commentary story. In America the people who rose and flew away from bondage were told of long before this retelling, in the legend of the flying Africans handed down along the Georgia and Carolina coast.

Little Creek Hundred, Kent County, Delaware

Kent County, Delaware, 1855

Delaware was a slave state that never seceded, with far more free Black residents than enslaved ones, and the main overland road north from Maryland's Eastern Shore ran up through it to Wilmington and Pennsylvania. Under the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 owners and their agents could pursue people into any state. The Quaker farmer John Hunn was fined so heavily for sheltering a family that his farm near Middletown was sold at sheriff's sale in 1848. Samuel Burris, a free Black conductor born in Kent County, was jailed and put on the auction block for the same work, and was bought and freed by an abolitionist posing as a trader. Much of the guiding was done by free Black Delawareans such as those of Star Hill, near the Quaker village of Camden. Large parties were rare but real: in October 1857 twenty-eight people, many of them children, left Dorchester County together in heavy rain.

Friends dated by number, so March was Third Month, and Delaware counties are still divided into hundreds. The bayside of Kent County is tidal salt marsh, now largely within Bombay Hook National Wildlife Refuge, where geese winter in great numbers and leave for the north in March; marshmen there lived by muskrat, salt hay and market gunning. St. Catharines, in what was then Canada West, was one of the chief places where people who had freed themselves settled. Abram Gibbs, the Lindleys and the thirty are invented, and no daybook records them.

After the story of the thirty bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 175). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

13.9

Only You and I

> *Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbour.*
> *— Exodus 20:16*

Se konsa m tande l, on the south side of Springfield.

I. Soup Joumou

Springfield, Ohio · January 1, 2024

On New Year's morning there was snow on the cars and the fellowship hall of the Methodist church on the south side smelled of squash and beef and scotch bonnet, because Frè Dieudonné had been up since four making soup joumou in the church's two big kettles, the way every Haitian house makes it on the first of January, for independence, because, the way the old people tell it, under the French the slaves cooked that soup for their masters and were not allowed to taste it.

By noon there were three hundred people in a hall built for a hundred and twenty. They stood along the walls with their coats on and their bowls in their hands. They came from the two-bedroom houses where fifteen of them lived on air mattresses waiting for work permits, and from the night shifts at the auto parts plants and the Amazon sorting center and the meatpacking plant, and from the apartments out by the highway where the landlords had doubled the rent. Some of them had been in Springfield three years and some three weeks. Many had come the long way, through Brazil or Chile, where they had gone after the earthquake and stayed ten years and learned Portuguese or Spanish and then walked north through nine countries. They ate standing up. Mrs. Marjorie Hale, who was seventy-eight and the head of what was left of the congregation, thirty-one members on a good Sunday, sat in a folding chair by the coffee

urn with a bowl in her lap and said it was the best soup she had ever eaten in that building, and she had eaten at every potluck since 1961.

Frè Dieudonné did not make a speech. He was sixty-three, small and very dark and very neat, with grey in his hair, and he had taught at a brothers' school in Port-au-Prince for thirty-one years until the gangs burned it, and in all that time he had never married. People said he had made a private vow. He did not say. In Springfield he worked from midnight to seven in the morning on the sanitation crew at the meatpacking plant, hosing blood off the steel in the steam and the cold, and in the afternoons he sat at a long table in the fellowship hall and helped people with their papers.

That was how it started. He read English and French and wrote a clear hand, and he filled out the forms for nothing. Work permits, asylum, the parole forms, school enrollment, Medicaid, the letters from the electric company. Then he started a class on Tuesday nights to teach grown people to read Creole, because half of them had never been taught to read their own language. Then on Sunday afternoons, when the Methodists had gone home, he began reading the Bible out loud in the hall and talking about it, plainly, for an hour. He took no offering. When people pushed money at him he told them to send it home. He lived in a back room of the empty parsonage next door, which Mrs. Hale let him have for mowing the church lawn and shoveling the walk.

By that New Year there were three hundred people coming on Sunday afternoons, and some of them had stopped going anywhere else.

II. Mirlande

A storefront on East Main Street · January

There were a dozen Haitian churches in Springfield by then, most of them in rented rooms, and two of them had been doing well. Pastè Wesner had a congregation of four hundred in a former tire store on East Main, with a sound system and a praise band and a sign in the window in Creole and English. Pastè Lucner had two hundred in a Pentecostal hall he rented on Sunday afternoons. And there was a man

WHO CALLED HIMSELF PWOFÈT FANFAN, WHO PRAYED FOR people on Facebook Live every night at nine and had twelve thousand followers and a Cash App.

All three of them, in the year before, had also done a good business in papers. Two hundred dollars to fill out an asylum application. A hundred and fifty for the work permit. A blessing on the envelope for twenty more. Then the people stopped coming. The tithes went down. Pastè Wesner's band had to let its drummer go. In January the three of them met in the back room of the tire store, under the fluorescent light, with the snow coming down past the window, and sat for a long time not saying what they had come to say.

Then Pastè Lucner said it. *He fills out the forms for free. He reads the Bible for free. Who can compete with free? Is he the only man of God in Springfield?*

He's never been married, said Pwofèt Fanfan. *Sixty-three years old, never married, lives alone in a back room. You think about that.*

They thought about it. And all three of them, at the same moment, thought of Mirlande.

Mirlande Augustin was twenty-four and sang the solos at Pastè Wesner's church, and when she sang the whole tire store went still. She had grown up in Cap-Haïtien and gone to Chile at fourteen with an aunt and worked eight years in a fruit-packing plant outside Santiago and come north through the Darién with a baby who died in Panama. People said that light came off her. People said she could stand at the back of a room and the room would turn around.

The next Sunday after the service she came to the back room as she always did, to greet the pastor, and stood in the doorway, and Pastè Wesner did not look up from his papers. Pastè Lucner was there too, and he did not look up either.

Pastè, she said. *What did I do?*

Nobody answered.

Pastè. Tell me. What did I do wrong?

Nobody answered. The third time she said it her voice cracked. *I'm asking you. What's wrong with me? Why won't you talk to me?*

Then Pastè Wesner looked up. *Sè Mirlande. You don't know what Frè Dieudonné is doing to us? Taking the bread out of our mouths? Taking the sheep out of the fold?*

I don't know him. I've never seen him. She looked from one to the other. *Is there something I can do?*

If you love this church, said Pastè Wesner, *you can help us. You can put a stop to him.*

She was quiet a moment.

All right, Pastè, said Mirlande. *Leave it to me. Don't worry about any of it.* And she went out.

III. The Red Dress

The south side · winter into summer

SHE HAD A RED DRESS, A LONG ONE, AND A RED WOOL COAT SHE had bought at the Goodwill. On Sunday evenings, when the three hundred people were coming out of the fellowship hall into the parking lot with their Bibles under their arms, Mirlande would be walking in, against the crowd, in the red coat, with a bunch of grocery-store roses and a little bottle of perfume in her hand.

Where are you going this time of night, Sè Mirlande?

What's it to you where I'm going?

She went around the side of the church toward the parsonage and did not come back. She spent those nights in Pastè Wesner's car, parked two streets over, with the engine running for the heat. And on Monday mornings a little after seven, when people were coming to the parsonage door to catch Frè Dieudonné on his way home from the plant and ask him to look at a letter before they went to work, there was Mirlande in the red coat walking the other way, down the parsonage steps.

Where did you sleep last night, Sè Mirlande?

What's it to you where I slept?

She did it for six weeks. Frè Dieudonné was at the plant every one of those nights, hosing the kill floor, with forty men who could have said so. Nobody thought to ask them.

At the end of six weeks, when somebody asked her where she had slept, she smiled and said, *In the parsonage. With Frè Dieudonné.*

It went into the WhatsApp groups that afternoon. By Wednesday everybody in Springfield who spoke Creole had heard it, and some of them had heard it four times. Most people did not believe it. But it was in them now, the way a splinter is in you, and every time they saw him at the long table with his reading glasses on, filling out somebody's form, they thought of it, and wondered, and were ashamed of wondering.

That spring there was another story going around Springfield, in English, on Facebook. Somebody said three Haitian men had been seen in the park grabbing a duck and a goose. Nobody had seen it. Nobody ever found who said it. It went around anyway, the way those things do, and people who had never met a Haitian repeated it at the Kroger, and Haitians heard them.

In April Mirlande began to wrap a folded towel around her belly under the red dress. In May it was a small pillow. She stopped singing solos. She went around the south side saying she was carrying Frè Dieudonné's child, and the date she gave was the night of a Monday in February when he had been on the kill floor until seven. It went into the WhatsApp groups again, with a photograph of her from the side.

Once, in the line at the long table, a woman from Gonaïves with a baby on her hip asked him straight out whether it was true. He looked at her over his reading glasses for a long moment, the way he used to look at a boy in the back row who had asked a question to make the others laugh, and then he asked her which form she had come about, and she showed him, and he filled it out.

Frè Dieudonné kept on. He filled out the forms. In June, when the government extended the protected status for Haitians and opened it to everyone who had come before the third of that month, there were lines out the fellowship hall door into the parking lot all summer, people with their passports in plastic bags, and he sat at the long table from two in the afternoon until eleven at night and then went to the plant. Some people stopped coming. Most did not. Mrs. Hale heard the story from a

woman at the Kroger and told her to go to hell, which was the first time anybody at the Methodist church had heard her say the word.

In August, a dozen men in red shirts, with their faces masked, marched through downtown Springfield carrying rifles and swastika flags, on a Saturday when the town had street events going downtown, shouting that the Haitians should go home. Mothers kept their children in. People missed shifts rather than wait at the bus stop. That Sunday there were fewer people in the fellowship hall, and the ones who came sat close.

That was the week Mirlande went to Pastè Wesner's deacon, who worked on a loading dock and had a saw, and had him cut a disk out of a pallet, a round of plywood the size of a serving tray, and sand the edges. She tied it against her belly with twine, under the red dress, with a towel between. Then, one night in her room, with the door locked, she took the wooden pilon her aunt had brought from Cap-Haïtien for pounding plantain and garlic, and beat her own hands and her feet and her back with it until they were black and swollen, so that she would look like a woman near her time.

IV. Only You and I

The fellowship hall · Sunday, September 8, 2024

The side door of the fellowship hall was propped open with a folding chair that Sunday to let in some air, because two hundred people in a room built for a hundred and twenty make their own weather. Frè Dieudonné sat on a stool at the front with his reading glasses on and the Bible open on his knee and was talking about the widow's mite, plainly, the way he talked about everything, when Mirlande came in through the side door.

She walked slowly, with one hand at the small of her back, the way women walk at nine months, and the hall went quiet around her. She came up the aisle between the folding chairs and stood in front of him. Her face was puffed. Her hands were swollen and dark. Under the red dress her belly was high and round.

Great teacher, she said, loud enough for the back row. *Look at all these people you have. Look how they come to hear you. Your voice is so sweet. Your mouth is so soft.* She let that sit. *And this is your child, and my time is any day now. And you haven't found me a midwife. You haven't found me a room. You haven't brought me so much as a bottle of oil or a can of milk. And if you won't do it yourself you could say to somebody, to Madame Hale, to the men with the restaurants, to any of the rich ones who sit in the front here, do what needs doing for this girl. You haven't said one word. You knew how to take your pleasure. You don't know how to take care of what you made.*

Nobody moved. Somebody's baby started to fuss and was quieted. Mrs. Hale, in the back row, who understood about one word in five of Creole, understood all of it.

Frè Dieudonné took off his reading glasses and closed the Bible on his finger. And then for the first and only time anybody could remember, he raised his voice, and it filled the hall to the ceiling tiles.

Sè m. My sister. Whether what you are saying is true or a lie, there are only two people in the world who know it. You and I.

That's right, said Mirlande. *Only you and I. So who's going to decide?*

That was when the mice came.

The fellowship hall had always had mice. Every old church in Springfield had them, and Mrs. Hale had given up on traps in 1990. Afterward, people agreed there were four. They came out from under the stage, all together, small and brown, and ran straight across the linoleum through two hundred pairs of feet and up under the hem of the red dress, and a woman in the front row screamed. Nobody saw what they did there. It took no time at all. Then they were gone again under the stage.

And a wind came in through the propped side door. It was a hot, sudden wind, the kind that comes before a storm, though nobody saw any storm that day. It came straight across the hall and lifted the red dress up to Mirlande's waist, and everyone in the front three rows saw the twine hanging cut, and the towel, and the round of plywood, which slid down her legs and fell edge first onto her feet.

She was wearing sandals. The plywood came down on her toes and cut them, both feet, to the bone. There was a great deal of blood on the linoleum.

For a moment nobody did anything. Then the hall came up out of its chairs.

People who had held their tongues for eight months, who had read it in the WhatsApp groups and wondered and been ashamed of wondering, came up out of their chairs at her, shouting. A man spat on her. Then a woman did. Then somebody threw a Bible, and somebody threw a shoe, and a cup of coffee, and Mirlande turned and ran out the side door the way she had come in, on her cut feet, leaving blood on the steps, and they went after her into the alley behind the church, some of them, and started picking up gravel. Frè Dieudonné was shouting at them to stop. Mrs. Hale was shouting at them to stop. Nobody was listening to either one of them.

Mirlande got as far as the corner of the alley, where it came out between the church and the parsonage, and stopped, because she could not see where to go.

And there, by every account that was ever given of it, the ground opened.

It opened under her and nowhere else. The people at the front of the crowd were close enough to touch her, and they said afterward that the asphalt simply was not there anymore, under her feet, and there was fire in the place where it had been, a red fire, and a heat that made them stagger back with their arms over their faces, and Mirlande went down into it in her red dress like somebody being wrapped up in a red blanket, and did not cry out. Then the ground closed. The asphalt was there, cracked the way it had always been cracked, with the same weeds in the cracks. There was gravel in people's hands. There was blood on the church steps and a smell of burning and nothing else.

Several people had been filming on their phones. What the phones show is no help to anybody. A bright square, then the alley, with nobody in it.

Her aunt filed a missing-person report on the Tuesday. Two officers came and walked up and down the alley and looked at the asphalt and wrote something down, and asked a great many questions, and went away. The round of plywood stayed on the floor of the fellowship hall until Wednesday, when Mrs. Hale picked it up with a dish towel and put it in the dumpster, and scrubbed the linoleum herself.

V. Krik? Krak!

The week of the lie · September 9–15

ON MONDAY THE OTHER STORY CAME BACK.

It came back bigger. The duck and the goose had turned into cats and dogs. Somebody on the internet said the Haitians in Springfield were eating people's pets, and somebody bigger said it again, and on Tuesday night a man running for president said it on television, at the debate, to the whole country. On Thursday morning somebody emailed bomb threats to City Hall and to the schools, and they emptied the buildings and sent the children home, and the Haitian children walked home past the police dogs. On Friday it happened again. That week a sign turned up in the grass of a city park, professionally lettered, PLEASE DO NOT EAT THE DUCKS, and on Friday the park workers took it down. People did not go to work. People stayed off the porch.

Pastè Wesner's church had forty people that Sunday. Pastè Lucner's had eleven. Pwofèt Fanfan did not go live on Facebook at all that week, or the next, and the Cash App went quiet, and by Christmas he had moved to Indiana.

The fellowship hall was full. There was a police car parked out front, which Mrs. Hale had asked for. People came in and sat close and did not say much. When it was time, Frè Dieudonné did not open the Bible. He sat on his stool and looked out at them, and then he said what the old people say before a story.

Krik?

There was a silence, because nobody had expected it. Then from the back an old woman said it. *Krak!* And then the whole hall said it. *Krak!*

There was a king, said Frè Dieudonné, *who had a son, a good boy, and the boy's mother died, and the king took a young wife. And the young wife looked at the son. And one day when the king was away she said to the son, come here to me. And the boy said, no, you are my father's wife. So she scratched her own face and tore her own dress and went to the king crying and said, your son did this to me because I wouldn't lie down with him.*

And the king believed her. He didn't ask anybody. He didn't look for himself. He took his son up on the cliff over the sea and threw him off.

But there was an old sea turtle down there in the water, as big as a fishing boat. And the turtle caught the boy on its back and carried him away to its island, and the turtles made him a king there, and gave him half of everything they had. He lived with them a year. Then he said, I thank you, but I want to go up into the mountains and pray. So he went up into the mountains, and you know what they say. Dèyè mòn, gen mòn. Behind the mountains, more mountains. He went up behind all of them, and lived there alone, and prayed, and got old.

One day a charcoal burner came up the mountain and saw him and went down and told the king. And the king climbed all the way up there, an old man himself by then, and found his son, and fell on the ground and cried. And he said, come home. Be king. Take all of it. And the son said, no, Papa. I don't want it. But you go home and rule right. Don't decide a thing you haven't seen with your own eyes. And the king went down the mountain crying, and he asked his men, whose fault was it that I lost a son like that? And they said, your wife's. So he took her up on the same cliff, and threw her off the same way. And there was no turtle for her.

And who was the son? said Frè Dieudonné. *In those old stories it's always the same boy. And who was the wife? It's always the same girl. She's been doing this a long time. And I was there, and they gave me a kick that sent me all the way here to tell it to you.*

Some people laughed, because that is how the old stories end, and it was the first time anybody in the hall had laughed in a week. Then they were quiet again.

Here is what I know about it, said Frè Dieudonné. *A person who will tell one lie like that, a lie all the way through, has stopped believing that anybody is*

watching. Not God. Not anybody. And after that there is nothing that person won't do. He opened the Bible then, his old French one with the cracked spine, and read it to them, and then, because Mrs. Hale was sitting in the back row in her cardigan, he read it again from the English one she had given him.

> *Le faux témoin ne restera pas impuni, Et celui qui dit des mensonges périra.*
>
> *A false witness shall not be unpunished, and he that speaketh lies shall perish.*
>
> *— Proverbes 19:9 (Louis Segond) · Proverbs 19:9 (King James)*

A young man near the front asked him about the other liars. The ones on television.

Frè Dieudonné closed the Bible on his finger.

Same verse, he said. *It doesn't say when.*

VI. A Saucer

The fellowship hall · that autumn

The Methodists voted in October to give the Haitians the use of the sanctuary as well as the hall, since there were thirty-one of them and three hundred of the others. Mrs. Hale made the motion. It passed thirty to one.

The lines for the papers went on all that fall, and Frè Dieudonné sat at the long table in the afternoons and went to the plant at midnight, and slept in the mornings in the back room of the parsonage, where anybody who wanted to could look in the window and see him sleeping alone in his clothes with his shoes on the floor beside the bed, and some people did.

Mrs. Hale said one evening that she would call the exterminator about the mice in the hall, now that there were so many people eating in there on Sundays. Frè Dieudonné asked her not to. She looked at him over her glasses for a while, and then said all right.

So after the soup on Sundays, when the folding chairs had been stacked and the kettles washed and the floor mopped, he would take a little rice and beans from the bottom of the pot and put it in a saucer, and set the saucer on the linoleum by the baseboard under the edge of the stage, where the four of them had come out. In the mornings, when he came off his shift and let himself in to start the coffee, the saucer was always clean.

Background

The verse

> *If a man has transgressed one law, and speaks lies, and scoffs at another world, there is no evil he will not do.*
>
> Dhammapada 176, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, rival ascetics in Sāvatthī lose their alms and honor as the Buddha's following grows, and they persuade Ciñcā, a beautiful young woman of their own order, to disgrace him. For months she walks toward his monastery in the evening in a red cloak, carrying perfume and flowers, sleeps at the rivals' place, and walks back in the morning, telling anyone who asks that it is none of their business; then she says she spends her nights with him. She binds cloths around her belly, then a disk of wood, bruises herself with an ox's jawbone, and accuses him before the whole assembly of fathering her child and abandoning her. He answers that only the two of them know whether it is true. The god Sakka sends four young gods as mice to gnaw through the cords, the wind lifts her cloak, and the disk falls and cuts off her toes. The crowd spits on her and drives her out with clods and sticks, and the earth opens and she is swallowed by fire "as if wrapped in a scarlet blanket." The Buddha tells the monks it is not the first time: in a former life, as a queen, she falsely accused a virtuous prince who had refused her, and the king threw him from a cliff; the prince was saved by a serpent king, became a hermit, and refused the throne when his father came to him, and the king threw the queen from the same cliff. Read the full commentary story.

Springfield, Ohio

Springfield, Ohio, 2024

Haitian immigrants began arriving in Springfield, an industrial city of about 59,000, around 2017, recruited to fill jobs in factories, warehouses and food processing. By 2024 there were an estimated 12,000 to 20,000 of them, most living in the country legally under humanitarian parole or Temporary Protected Status, which the federal government extended and redesignated for Haiti in June 2024. Many Haitians who came north in those years had first spent years in Brazil or Chile after the 2010 earthquake. Every January 1, Haitian households mark independence with soup joumou, the squash soup that, in the story Haitians tell, enslaved people were forbidden to eat under French rule.

In March 2024, unfounded rumors began that Haitians were taking ducks and geese from city parks. On August 10 about a dozen members of a neo-Nazi group marched through downtown with swastika flags. In early September a secondhand Facebook post claiming Haitians were eating pets went viral; on September 9 the Republican vice-presidential nominee repeated it, and on September 10 the presidential nominee repeated it in a televised debate. City, county and police officials said there was no evidence for any of it. Beginning September 12, Springfield received dozens of emailed bomb threats that emptied City Hall, schools and other buildings. More on the Springfield pet-eating hoax.

After the story of the young brahmin woman Ciñcā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 176). The original. Scripture from the King James Version and the Louis Segond Bible (1910). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

13.10

The Sopas

To what purpose is this waste?
— Matthew 26:8 (Douay-Rheims)

Foi assim que me contaram, at the hall in Valeta.

I. The Domingas

Valeta, Merced County, California · spring 2022

Frank Mendonça milked fifty-eight hundred cows on two dairies on the west side of the county, and in the spring of 2022, for the first time in his life, milk was worth what it cost to make and then some. The checks that came from the co-op in April were the biggest anybody in Valeta had ever seen. Feed was dear and diesel was dear and the drought had the canals running at a third, but the price of a hundredweight of milk went past twenty-five dollars, and the dairymen who had held on through 2009 and 2015 and the years between drove to Mass in new trucks and did not apologize for it.

That was also the first spring in three that the hall could keep the festa the old way. In 2020 there had been no festa. In 2021 the ladies had put the sopas into foam boxes and handed them out of the kitchen window to cars. So everybody wanted to give. That was the trouble, if it was trouble.

Valeta was one of the last halls in California that still kept the *domingas* the way they kept them on Terceira, where Frank had been born and where his father had come from in 1971 with eleven cows' worth of savings and four children. From Easter to Pentecost the silver crown of the Holy Ghost, with the dove on top, went home each week with a different family. They made an altar for it in the front room with white cloth and gladiolas. Every night the neighbors came and prayed the terço in front

of it, and on the Sunday the family that had the crown gave a dinner, and then the crown went back to church and out again to the next house.

Frank took the first week. Three hundred people ate tri-tip and sopas under the walnut trees at the home dairy. On the second Sunday the crown went to the Machados, who milked four hundred cows, and the Machados, the Silveiras, the Avilas and half the hall put their money together. The ladies of the auxiliary cooked for two days. Six hundred people ate. Frank's wife told him how many. He said nothing. The third week he had the crown back by arrangement and fed nine hundred. On the fourth the hall answered with twelve hundred and a band from San Jose. Frank fed fifteen hundred on the fifth, with a fado singer flown in from Ponta Delgada. On the sixth Sunday the hall, which by now meant everybody in Valeta who was not Frank, fed two thousand people and put on a bloodless bullfight in the arena behind the hall, with a cavaleiro from Portugal on a grey horse.

Nobody had planned it. It had simply happened, the way the price of milk had happened, and nobody could stop it now. The old women said it was a scandal and loved every minute.

On Memorial Day, the Monday after the bullfight, Frank Mendonça did not go out to the dairy. He lay on the recliner in the den with the blinds down and the television on with no sound. When the foreman called, he did not pick up.

II. São

The home dairy · Memorial Day

His wife found him there at noon. Conceição Mendonça was sixty-four and had been born in Valeta, in the house behind the hall where her father was caretaker, and in 1975 she had been the festa queen, at seventeen, in a cape of red velvet four yards long that her mother had embroidered with wheat and doves by hand. Everybody called her São.

What's this, she said. *Are you sick?*

You don't know?

I don't know anything. Tell me.

So he told her, lying in the recliner with his boots still on. That he was the biggest dairyman on the west side of the county and the president of the festa that year, and the hall had outgiven him every second Sunday since Easter. That there was one Sunday left, the big one, Pentecost, and he could not see how to beat two thousand people and a bullfight. That if Frank Mendonça could not outgive the hall in Valeta in the best milk year there had ever been, he did not know what he was for.

São looked at him for a while.

Have you ever heard, she said, *of a king who lets the people beat him? Get up. I'll do the festa.*

She sat on the arm of the recliner and told him how, counting on her fingers.

The dairy had shade cloth, the white cloth they stretched over the feed lanes so the cows could eat in July. He should have his men put it up on poles over the whole lot behind the hall, the parking and the arena and the lawn, so that fifteen hundred people could sit down at once out of the sun. The hall did not have that cloth and could not buy it by Sunday.

The copper kettles in the hall kitchen, the old ones, the ones from before the steam kettles, should be polished until they looked like gold, and set out under the shade where people could see them.

She would call the queens. Every festa queen of Valeta she could find, going back to 1950. Most of them were still alive and most of them still had their capes in garment bags in a back closet. They would come in their capes and wait on the tables themselves. They would pour the broth. Nobody had ever seen that. The hall could not make it happen because the hall did not have São, who had been the queen of 1975 and the mother of the queens of 1997 and 2001 and the grandmother of the queen of 2019, and had every one of their telephone numbers.

She would strip every mint bed in Valeta, and there would be a sprig of fresh mint on every plate of sopas, so the smell of it would be under the shade cloth all afternoon.

And in the Saturday procession every queen would walk beside a heifer from Frank's herd, washed and brushed, with paper flowers on her

halter. One heifer for every queen. The Machados had four hundred cows. The Mendonças had fifty-eight hundred.

And the first tables, she said, *don't go to us. They go to the milkers and their families. Ours and everybody's. And the men from the shelter in Merced, and the old people from the senior apartments, and the people who pick the almonds. They sit down first and the queens serve them. That's how the queen did it. The real one.* She meant the Queen Isabel of the old story, who fed the poor out of her own kitchen in a famine. *The hall has never done that either.*

Frank sat up.

That's good, he said. *That's very good.*

He put his boots on the floor and called the foreman back.

III. The Bull

The road to the church · Saturday, June 4

SIXTY-TWO QUEENS CAME. THE OLDEST WAS EIGHTY-SEVEN, the queen of 1952, in a cape of white satin gone the color of cream, with her granddaughter holding up the train. The youngest had been crowned the year before in an empty church in a mask. They came from Hilmar and Gustine and Turlock and Tulare and one from Boise, and they stood in the hall parking lot on Saturday morning in their capes, red and blue and white and gold, embroidered with doves and wheat and roses and crowns, while the dairy crew led the heifers down off the trailers.

On Friday night one of the heifers had gone lame. There were sixty-one.

Frank found São behind the trailers. *One queen doesn't have a heifer,* he said. *What do I do?*

What do you mean? There are cattle all over that dairy.

Gentle ones. Halter-broke. The rest are milk cows that never saw a crowd, and they'll go crazy. There's nothing left on the trailers but the bull.

Everybody on the home dairy knew the bull. He was a Holstein two years old, black and white, a ton already, bred from the best line in the herd and kept for that. In March he had put a milker named Rigoberto through a pipe gate and into the hospital in Merced with four broken

ribs. The milkers called him Chamuco, which is a name for the devil. Nobody went in the pen with him alone.

I know a place he can walk, São said.

Where?

Beside Nelson.

Nelson Rocha was forty-three years old and worked in the calf barn at the home dairy, mixing milk replacer and feeding bottles to the newborn calves twice a day. In 1996, when he was seventeen, he had stabbed a boy to death in a fight behind the county fairgrounds, over nothing anybody could remember afterward, and he had been sentenced to twenty-five years to life. He had been in Folsom and Corcoran and Solano. After a law passed in Sacramento in 2013 gave men who had done their crimes before they were eighteen a special parole hearing in their twenty-fifth year, he had his hearing, and the board found him suitable, and the governor let it stand, and in the summer of 2021 he came home to Valeta. Nelson's father had milked for Frank's father for thirty years. Frank gave him the calf barn because nobody else would give him anything. The boy Nelson had killed was a Machado cousin. The Machados were in the parking lot that morning, and the dead boy's mother, and everybody knew it.

Frank looked at his wife a long time. Then he sent for the bull.

They brought him down off the last trailer with two men on the lead and the crew standing back. Frank's foreman put the lead in Nelson's hand. Nelson took it without a word and walked the bull out to his place at the back of the procession, beside the last queen, who was São, because São had given her own heifer to the girl from Boise.

The bull stopped beside Nelson and put his tail down between his legs. He dropped his ears. He closed his eyes. He stood there with his great head hanging, perfectly still, and did not move again until Nelson moved, and then he walked when Nelson walked, the whole mile to the church and the whole mile back, with São in her red cape on the other side of him, and stood with his eyes shut on the church steps while the band played. Children came up and put their hands flat on his side. He let them.

People along the road took out their phones. People who had known that bull since he was a calf stood with their mouths open. One of the old milkers from Michoacán crossed himself.

Look at that animal, people said. *Look how he walks.*

IV. Four Lines

The hall · Pentecost Sunday, June 5

After the Mass and the crowning and the parade, the people came in under the shade cloth.

Frank's crew had worked two nights stringing it. It covered the whole lot from the hall to the arena fence, white, a little translucent, and the noon light came down through the weave of it soft and even, so that it was like sitting inside a cloud. Under it were tables for fifteen hundred and the copper kettles on their stands, polished so that they threw the light back, and the smell of the sopas, which is beef and cabbage and bread and allspice and cinnamon cooked down all night, and over everything the smell of the mint. São had stripped the mint beds of half the town. A sprig of it lay on every plate.

The first tables went to the milkers and their wives and children, from every dairy on the west side, and the almond pickers, and the men from the shelter, and the old people from the senior apartments who came on the church van. They sat down and looked around them, not sure. Then the queens came down the rows in their capes, the queen of 1952 on her granddaughter's arm, the queen of 1975, the queen of the empty church, sixty-two of them, carrying pitchers of broth. They bent and poured it over the bread in the bowls and laid the meat on top with their own hands, then went back for more. The capes dragged in the gravel. Nobody minded. Some of the milkers' wives were crying. A boy from the shelter asked the queen of 1966 if she was a real queen, and she said, *Today, honey,* and gave him another piece of meat.

Before anybody ate, the priest blessed the sopas. That was always the custom. When old Father Goulart had been alive, he had stood in front of the kettles every Pentecost for thirty-one years and blessed the food in

Portuguese for twenty minutes by the clock, the Holy Ghost and Queen Isabel and the founders of the hall by name, the dead of the year by name, the cattle and the rain and the price of milk, until the broth went cold and the children cried. People had complained about it every year. Everybody missed it.

Father Goulart had died in 2019. The priest now was Father Ikenna Nwosu, who was thirty-four years old and came from Nnewi, in the southeast of Nigeria, and had been lent by his bishop to the Diocese of Fresno for three years because the diocese did not have priests enough to go around. He had learned to say Mass in Portuguese from a book and from the old women of the parish, who corrected him after every Mass in the vestibule, and he said it slowly and very correctly with an accent nobody in Valeta had ever heard before. He was tall and very quiet. He did not talk much at the best of times. The old women had decided in his first month that they loved him, and he had not been able to do anything about it.

Frank took him by the elbow up to the kettles and stood beside him with his hat off. Everybody under the shade cloth went quiet.

Father Ikenna looked out at it all a long time. The white cloth, the copper, the queens in their capes, the milkers' children, the men from the shelter, the mint on the plates. He looked at Frank. Then he looked over Frank's shoulder at two men standing by the end kettle, and his face changed, and he looked from one of them to the other.

One of them was Darren Pimentel, who was the controller for Mendonça Dairies, a careful man from Fresno with a degree in accounting, who had worked for Frank six years and kept his books cleaner than any dairy books in the county. Darren was standing by the kettle with his phone in his hand, adding. He had been adding all week. The shade cloth alone, with the poles and the labor, came to more than forty thousand. The sixty-one heifers, which Frank had told the hall that morning were to be auctioned and every dollar given away and matched out of his pocket. The flights for the queens who came from far off, which Frank had paid. The beef and the bread. The tables. The overtime for the crew. Darren had the number on the screen of his phone, and it was more than

three hundred thousand dollars, in one day, in one parking lot. And he was thinking: in the best year he will ever have, he has thrown this away. In one afternoon. And all these people will eat it and go home and lie down and take a nap.

The other was Frank's uncle Lucindo, who was eighty-two and had been secretary of the hall since 1979, a little dry man in a white shirt buttoned to the neck. Lucindo was standing a step behind Darren, and the tears were running down his face, and he was thinking: nobody but Frank could have done this. Nobody in Valeta has ever seen anything like it. And it is for everybody, every one of them, Portuguese or not, and the poor first. Thank God I lived to see it.

Father Ikenna looked at the two of them for a long moment. Then he lifted his right hand over the kettles and said, in English, the grace that every Catholic child in America learns before the first grade.

Bless us, O Lord, and these thy gifts, which we are about to receive from thy bounty, through Christ our Lord. Amen.

He made the sign of the cross over the food. He took the aspergillum from the altar boy and shook holy water over the kettles, once, twice, three times, and gave it back. He ate one bowl of sopas, standing, by the kitchen door. And then, before the auction, before the dancing, before anyone had thought to stop him, he got into his car and drove back to the rectory.

• • •

That evening, after the auction, Frank stood up on the stage in the hall in front of everybody and said that whatever was left over in the hall that night, the meat and the bread and the broth and the kettles of it, belonged to whoever wanted to take it home, and the hall should open its kitchen door and let them. The heifers had brought two hundred and eight thousand dollars at the auction. Frank said he would match it, and it would all go to the food bank in Merced and the farmworker clinic and the shelter. The hall stood up and clapped for a long time.

Frank did not hear much of it. He went home and lay down again.

V. The Rectory

Valeta · Monday, June 6

In the morning, in the hall kitchen, the ladies scrubbing the kettles asked Nelson Rocha, who had come to help carry, whether he had not been afraid on Saturday, walking a mile with that animal on a rope.

No, Nelson said. *I wasn't afraid.*

One of the Machado men, who was stacking chairs, said loud enough for the kitchen to hear that a man who had done twenty-five years would say anything. Nobody answered him. Nelson went on carrying.

Later, when somebody told Father Ikenna about it, the priest said: *He told you the truth. That man has nothing left in him to be afraid with.*

• • •

Frank had not slept. He had lain awake all night thinking: I gave the best gift anybody in this valley ever gave, and the priest said four lines over it, the same four lines a child says over a peanut-butter sandwich, and walked out. Father Goulart would have talked an hour. It must be that I did it wrong. It must be that I gave the wrong things, or gave them the wrong way, or that the priest is angry with me about something, because a priest always blesses a gift in proportion to the gift. Everybody knows that.

At eight he drove to the rectory. Father Ikenna was in the kitchen in his shirtsleeves making tea, and he made Frank a cup and sat down across from him.

Father. Did I do something wrong yesterday? Did I give the wrong thing?

Why do you ask?

Four lines. You said four lines and you left.

What you gave was right, the priest said. *All of it. The cloth and the queens and the poor first. A gift like that a man gives once in his life, maybe. Nobody in this valley will see one like it again.*

Then why?

Father Ikenna turned his cup on the table.

Because the company was not clean, he said. *There were two men by the end kettle. One of them was so glad for what you did that he was crying. The other one was sick to his heart over the money. Sick. He stood there adding it up and hating every bowl. If I had blessed that food the way it deserved, the way Father Goulart would have, the whole hour, with all of them listening, I think it would have broken something in him that does not mend. I was sorry for him. So I said the short one.*

He told Frank which two men.

Frank drove straight to the office at the home dairy. Darren was at his desk with the spreadsheet open.

Is it true, Frank said, *what you were thinking yesterday by the kettle?*

Darren looked at him and did not ask how he knew. He was an honest man in his way. *Yes,* he said. *It's true. It's my job to think it, Frank. Somebody has to.*

Frank stood in the doorway.

I never took one dollar that was yours, he said. *Not one. What I gave yesterday I gave out of my own, with my wife and my children. What did I do to you? Take what's yours and go. I'll pay you through the year. I don't want to see you at the dairy, and I don't want to see you at the hall.*

Darren went back to Fresno that week. He found other dairies to keep books for. He was good at it.

Then Frank drove out to the hall, where his uncle Lucindo was sitting in the little office off the kitchen with the festa ledger open, writing in the totals by hand the way he had since 1979.

Tio. Is it true what you were thinking yesterday?

The old man did not ask how he knew either. *It's true,* he said.

Good, said Frank. *That's good, tio. I'm glad.* He put the checkbook for the festa account on the desk in front of his uncle, and his own credit card on top of it. *Then you do it. All this week. Every day, the way we did it yesterday. Whatever it costs. Whoever comes.*

• • •

He went back to the rectory before noon. The priest was in the garden with the hose.

Father, Frank said, *look what that man did to me. I gave all that, and he stands there and does that.* And he told him the rest, what he had said to Darren in the doorway, word for word.

Father Ikenna turned off the hose. He went into the rectory and came back with an old Bible with a cracked black cover, the Douay, that had been Father Goulart's and was still full of his holy cards, and turned the pages with his wet thumb, and gave it to Frank open.

You said it already, he said. *Read it.*

> *But he answering said to one of them: Friend, I do thee no wrong: didst thou not agree with me for a penny? Take what is thine, and go thy way: I will also give to this last even as to thee. Or, is it not lawful for me to do what I will? is thy eye evil, because I am good?*
>
> *— Matthew 20:13–15 (Douay-Rheims)*

Frank read it twice standing on the path. Then the priest took the book back and found another place and read it out himself, slowly, in his careful English.

> *Now this I say: He who soweth sparingly, shall also reap sparingly: and he who soweth in blessings, shall also reap blessings. Every one as he hath determined in his heart, not with sadness, or of necessity: for God loveth a cheerful giver.*
>
> *— 2 Corinthians 9:6–7 (Douay-Rheims)*

Not with sadness, he said. *The man who stands beside a gift and cannot be glad for it, he is the poor one. He goes hungry at the biggest table in the world. And the one who can be glad for another man's gift, even if he gave nothing, he eats.* He closed the book. *Your uncle ate very well yesterday.*

VI. The Octave

The hall · June 6 to 12

Lucindo Mendonça fed Valeta for seven days.

He kept the shade cloth up. He kept the kettles going. He called the ladies of the auxiliary and they came, and the milkers' wives came to help them without being asked, and on Tuesday some of the queens came back in their capes, and on Wednesday more. Every day at noon he opened the gates and fed whoever walked in, the same as on Pentecost, the poor first, and he sat at the end of the first table himself and ate with them, which in forty-three years as secretary he had never once done. People who had known him all their lives said he was changed. They could not say how. His sister-in-law said that he laughed now, at nothing, at the children, at the mint, and that he had never laughed before in his life that she could remember.

Nelson Rocha carried kettles all week, and at five every morning and five every evening he went back to the calf barn and fed the calves. On Thursday the Machado man who had called him a liar came into the hall kitchen and stood next to him at the sink and dried what Nelson washed. Neither of them said anything. On Friday the dead boy's mother sat at the first table. Nelson poured her broth. Her hand shook on the spoon, and his on the pitcher, and that was all.

On the last evening, Sunday, after the last people had gone, Lucindo locked the kitchen and went out under the shade cloth to look at it all one more time before Frank's crew took it down in the morning.

The sun was low over the Coast Range and coming in sideways under the edge of the cloth. The light through the weave of it lay across the empty tables and the swept gravel in a fine net of bright squares, thousands of them, each one with the same light in it, and when the evening wind lifted the cloth the whole net moved at once. In the gravel between the tables, everywhere, trodden flat by a week of feet, were the stems of the mint, and they were still green.

Background

The verse

> *The uncharitable do not go to the world of the gods; fools only do not praise liberality; a wise man rejoices in liberality, and through it becomes blessed in the other world.*
>
> Dhammapada 177, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi of Kosala and the citizens of his capital try to outdo each other in feeding the Buddha and his monks, and the citizens keep winning. The king lies down in despair until Queen Mallikā devises gifts only a king could give: a pavilion of sāla wood, five hundred white parasols held by five hundred elephants, golden boats of perfume, noblewomen to fan and serve the monks. One monk lacks an elephant; the only one left is a rogue, and Mallikā has it stand beside Aṅgulimāla, the reformed murderer, where it drops its ears, shuts its eyes and stands motionless. These are the "Gifts beyond Compare," given once in each Buddha's lifetime, and always, the commentary notes, arranged by a woman. But of the king's two ministers, Kāla resents the waste while Juṇha rejoices, and the Buddha, out of pity for Kāla, gives only a four-line blessing. When the king learns why, he banishes Kāla, gives Juṇha the kingdom's means to give alms for seven days, and the Buddha speaks this verse. Read the full commentary story, or about King Pasenadi.

Merced County, California

The San Joaquin Valley, 2022

Azorean immigrants brought the festas of the Holy Spirit to California in the nineteenth century. In the Azores the silver crown, topped with a dove, passes from house to house on the Sundays between Easter and Pentecost, with the rosary prayed before it each night. The devotion is traced to Queen Isabel of Portugal, who fed the poor in a famine. California festas add crowned girl queens and a free meal for everyone who comes. In Gustine, in Merced County, dairymen lead decorated calves

in the procession, the animals are auctioned for the society's charity, and volunteers serve sopas of beef, cabbage and bread.

In 2022 U.S. dairy farmers saw record milk prices, averaging $25.39 per hundredweight, though high feed and labor costs ate into margins and prices fell the next year. California's youth offender parole hearings, created by SB 260 in 2014 for people whose crimes were committed before age 18, give special weight to youth and later growth; for those serving 25 years to life, the hearing comes in the twenty-fifth year. With fewer American vocations, U.S. dioceses have increasingly recruited priests from Africa, including Nigeria.

After the story of the Gifts beyond Compare from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 177). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

13.11

The Luminaria

My richest gain I count but loss.
— Isaac Watts, "When I survey the wondrous cross"

Here's what I heard, in Papillion.

I. The Plate Lunch

Papillion, Nebraska · spring 2019

Kawika Chun ran a plate-lunch place in a strip mall on the south side of Papillion, between a nail salon and a State Farm office, and he fed more people for nothing than anybody in Sarpy County.

He had come out of the Army in 2010 with a wife from Papillion and a six-year-old son and no plan, and the plan he made was rice, macaroni salad and two scoops of whatever, the way his grandmother had made it in Hilo. He called the place Kwai's, after her father, who had kept a store on Mamo Street before the war. The airmen from Offutt found it the first month, the ones from Hawaii and Guam and Samoa and then everybody else, and after the airmen the high-school wrestlers, and after them the Methodists. On Sundays after two he fed anybody in a uniform for nothing, and anybody who looked like they needed it, and sent them home with a foil pan of whatever was left. When the Missouri came over the levees in March of 2019 and put a third of the air base under water, he cooked for nine days straight and drove the pans out to the shelters himself, and lost money every one of those days, and did not seem to notice.

People asked him where he got it. He said he learned it at Fort Lewis, from a Samoan longshoreman on the Hilltop in Tacoma who cooked an umu every Sunday under a blue tarp for whoever came, and never asked a

soldier his name, and sent him home every week with a pan. *Kale used to ride on my shoulders over there,* he would say. *He doesn't remember.*

Over the pass-through between the kitchen and the counter hung a framed Chinese print, a lady in a red jacket with a baby on her arm and two little boys at her skirt. There was a brown stain straight across all three of them at the height of a child's chin. Kawika's grandmother Lin, who was eighty-one and still came in to fold wontons on Tuesdays, had brought it from Hilo. Customers asked about the stain. Lin said it was the ocean.

Kale was fifteen, then sixteen in May. He had his father's shoulders and his mother's Nebraska face and no interest in any of it.

What Kale was interested in was shoes. He had a bot that bought sneakers the second they dropped online, and an account on StockX, the site that sold them again like shares of stock with a little graph of the price, and a closet full of boxes he did not wear. He knew the asking price of every pair in the closet the way his great-great-grandfather had known the price of rice. That May the Travis Scott Jordan 1s came out, brown suede with the swoosh put on backwards, a hundred seventy-five dollars retail, and sold out in a morning, and by that afternoon people were asking more than a thousand. Kale's bot had missed them. He talked about nothing else for a month.

When the Relay team came in to eat, Kale went in the back. When his father asked him to carry pans out to a car, he was busy. He had never once worked the Sunday line. His father said *Kale, don't,* about a dozen things a week, and Kale did them anyway, not angrily, the way water goes around a rock.

One night Kawika sat at the kitchen table after close and said to his grandmother that he was scared for the boy. Not of drugs, not of anything like that. Scared he would grow up to be one of those men who know what everything costs. *That kind of man,* he said, *goes to hell before he dies. You can watch it happen.*

Lin went on folding the wonton she had in her hand.

Everybody can be bought, she said. *Buy him.*

II. The Track

The high-school track · Saturday, June 8, all night

Every June the American Cancer Society's Relay For Life took over the track at the high school from six on Saturday evening until six on Sunday morning. Teams pitched tents on the infield and took turns walking laps all night. It ran twenty-four hours because the people it was for did not get to stop either. Kawika ran the food tent for nothing and had for eight years: teriyaki at dinner, Spam musubi at midnight, pancakes at five.

The team Kawika fed best was called Carol's Crew. It was eleven people, mostly over sixty, in purple T-shirts with a photograph of a smiling woman on the back, and it was led, if anybody led it, by a retired shop teacher named Dale Petersen.

Dale was seventy-four. He had taught industrial arts at the high school for thirty-eight years. Half the men in Papillion who could cut a dado had learned it from him. He was tall and stooped, with big scarred hands and a short grey haircut. He wore the same khaki pants and the same purple shirt every Relay. He mowed his lawn on Saturdays at seven in the morning, which some of his neighbors had complained about for forty years. His wife Carol had died of ovarian cancer in the summer of 2009. Since then Dale had walked every lap of every Relay in Papillion from the opening ceremony until dawn. He did not run them or hurry them. He walked them the way a man walks to his mailbox, and he hardly spoke, and the others on his team would fall in beside him for a lap or two and then fall off, the way people do beside a person like that.

On Friday Kawika had said to his son: *A hundred dollars. Cash. If you stay at the Relay all night with Carol's Crew, sundown to sunup, and come home in the morning.*

A hundred? For real?

For real.

Kale made him say it three times. Then he said fine.

He came at six. He walked the survivors' lap behind the survivors because everybody did. At dusk, when the luminaria were lit, he stood at

the back. The luminaria were white paper bags weighted with sand, a candle in each one, set all the way around the inside of the track, hundreds of them, and people had written names on them in marker and drawn hearts and crosses and Husker logos. When they were lit and the stadium lights went off, the whole oval glowed, and the names showed through the paper from inside. Kale saw Dale Petersen kneel by one bag on the far turn with a long butane lighter and light it, and stay there on one knee for a while. Then Dale got up and started walking. Kale went back to his father's truck in the parking lot, put the seat back and opened StockX on his phone. He was asleep by ten.

He woke at five to the smell of pancakes and the sky going grey over the bleachers. Dale Petersen was coming around the far turn, alone, at the same pace.

At the food tent his father had a plate ready for him: pancakes, two eggs, Portuguese sausage. *You did it,* Kawika said. *Eat.*

Where's my hundred?

Eat first.

Not till I get it.

Kale stood there with his arms folded while the plate went cold on the table between them. His father had fed whole flooded neighborhoods, had fed men who could not pay and men who would not, and he could not stand to watch one person not eat in front of him, least of all his son. He took out his wallet and counted five twenties onto the plate beside the eggs. Kale put them in his pocket and ate everything, and asked for more sausage.

III. The Garage

A cul-de-sac off Lincoln Street · Sunday

That afternoon, after Kale had slept again, his father found him on the couch.

Last night at the luminaria, Kawika said, *Mr. Petersen sang something. By himself, by his wife's bag. A hymn. I heard it from the tent.* He took an envelope out of his shirt pocket and set it on the coffee table. *That's a thousand*

dollars. You go to his house and learn one verse of that hymn by heart. And what it means. You say it to him and he says you've got it, it's yours.

Kale looked at the envelope. A thousand dollars was the Travis Scotts.

One verse.

One verse.

Dale's house was a split-level at the end of a cul-de-sac with the straightest lawn in Sarpy County. The garage door was up. Dale was inside at the workbench, in the same purple shirt, sanding a long board of white oak with a block and a sheet of paper, while a box fan pushed the dust out the door. Along the wall were the bones of a bench: legs, rails, a back slat with letters cut into it that Kale could not read from the driveway.

Kale told him what his father wanted. Dale listened, and nodded, and went on sanding. Then he said it, plain, without singing, the way you would read off a measurement.

When I survey the wondrous cross, on which the Prince of Glory died, my richest gain I count but loss, and pour contempt on all my pride.

Kale had it in two tries. He said it back. Dale nodded.

What's it mean, Dale said.

Kale thought. *Richest gain I count but loss,* he said. *That's, like. You take your best flip and you book it as a loss. For taxes. So you come out ahead.*

Dale looked at him a while over the board.

Could be, he said, and went back to sanding.

Kale stood there. It had been too easy, and he knew it, and he could see that Dale knew it, and Dale had not said *you've got it.* He had said *could be.* Kale did not want to go back to his father with *could be.*

Is there more of it?

Four more.

Then let me hear the next one.

Dale handed him a sanding block and the other end of the board.

That was how it went all afternoon. Dale gave him the next verse, about boasting and the vain things that charm me most. Kale thought he had it and said what he thought it meant. Dale said *could be,* and Kale could see it was not. So he asked for the next. Dale gave it to him

between passes of the block, a line at a time, never more, and after every verse Kale's answer was a little less sure and his hands were a little steadier on the wood. When the board was done, Dale laid a steel straightedge on it edgewise and held it up to the light from the driveway, and there was a thin line of sky under the middle of it, and Dale handed it back without a word. Kale sanded it again. They did that four times. The fifth time there was no light under the edge at all, and Dale ran his thumb down the board, and Kale saw that the fourth time it had been good enough for anybody but Dale, and that Dale did not care about anybody.

The fourth verse Dale gave him was in brackets in the old book, he said, the one most churches skipped.

Then am I dead to all the globe, and all the globe is dead to me.

Kale said it back and did not say what it meant. He did not know. It was getting dark. The fireflies had come up out of the lawns all down the cul-de-sac, and the sprinklers ticked, and somebody's television was going with a ballgame. Dale turned on the light over the bench. He picked up the back slat of the bench and set it in front of Kale on the bench top, and Kale read the letters cut into it. CAROL ANN PETERSEN 1947–2009. SHE FED EVERYBODY.

For the park by the track, Dale said. *So the walkers have someplace to sit.*

Then, while Kale sanded the slat, Dale told him one thing, in about six sentences, which was more than Kale had ever heard him say. That in the summer of 2009 he had sat by her bed at the Methodist hospital in Omaha every night for eleven weeks. That before that he had been a man who knew what everything cost, the price of oak by the board foot, the price of a lawn mower, the price of the house, and had been proud of knowing it. That at the end he would have given every one of those things and the whole globe for one more Saturday of her yelling at him for mowing at seven. That nobody had offered him the trade. That he had found out, sitting there, that there was something underneath all of it that you did not buy and could not lose, and she had been standing in it the whole time, and now so was he.

He stopped. That was all of it.

Kale went on sanding the slat in the light over the bench, around the letters, carefully, into the cuts. Somewhere in that hour, with the fan going and the fireflies out on the lawns and the dust in the light, the thing Dale was talking about came up underneath him too. He could not have said what it was. It was like the board when the light finally stopped showing under the straightedge. It had been there the whole time. It was not going to stop being there. He stayed until eleven. He learned all five verses. He did not think about the shoes once, and later, when he noticed that, it scared him a little.

IV. The Envelope

Kwai's · Monday morning

Every year on the Monday after the Relay, Kawika opened early for Carol's Crew and fed them breakfast for nothing. Kale rode over with Dale in his truck, with the finished bench in the bed under a moving blanket, and walked into his father's place in the middle of eleven old people in purple shirts. Kawika looked up from the grill and saw his son come in among them, and something in his face went still.

Kale, for his part, was praying the only prayer he had. He was praying his father would not bring up the money. Not here. Not in front of Mr. Petersen, who would know then that it had been for a thousand dollars, and the afternoon in the garage with it.

But Dale knew already. Dale had known from the driveway.

Kawika fed the team first. Loco moco, two eggs over the hamburger patty and the brown gravy over all of it, and fried rice, and coffee. Then he made a plate for his son and set it down in front of him at the end of the long table, and Kale ate it without a word, all of it, every grain. Lin came out of the back in her apron and sat down beside him and patted his arm, not knowing why.

When the plates were cleared, Kawika came over and laid the envelope on the table in front of Kale, in front of Dale, in front of everybody.

You remember, he said, *I said a thousand dollars if you learned the verse. Here's your thousand dollars.*

Kale felt his whole face go hot. He looked at the envelope and did not touch it.

I don't want it, he said.

Take it. You earned it.

Dad. I don't want it.

Kawika stood there with his hand still out. He looked at his son a long time. Then he turned to Dale Petersen, the way a man turns to someone who knows more about it than he does.

I like the way he is today, he said. *I don't understand it, but I like it. Saturday he wouldn't eat his breakfast till I paid him a hundred bucks. Today I put a thousand in front of him and he won't touch it.*

Dale turned his coffee cup a quarter turn on the table. He did not sing it. He said it the way he had said everything in the garage, like a measurement he had checked.

> *Were the whole realm of nature mine,*
> *That were a present far too small;*
> *Love so amazing, so divine,*
> *Demands my soul, my life, my all.*
>
> *— Isaac Watts, Hymns and Spiritual Songs (1707), Book III, Hymn 7*

He got the verse, Dale said. *You don't pay for that. You couldn't if you tried.*

• • •

Carol's Crew carried the bench out to the park by the track that afternoon and bolted it to a concrete pad facing the far turn, where Dale had knelt with the lighter. Kale held the slat level while Dale drove the lag bolts.

The envelope stayed on the counter at Kwai's all week, under the napkin dispenser, because nobody in the family would pick it up. On Sunday at two, when the line of airmen and wrestlers and whoever else came through, Kale was behind the counter in an apron for the first time in his life, filling foil pans. His grandmother watched him from her stool by the pass-through, under the lady in the red jacket with the water line across

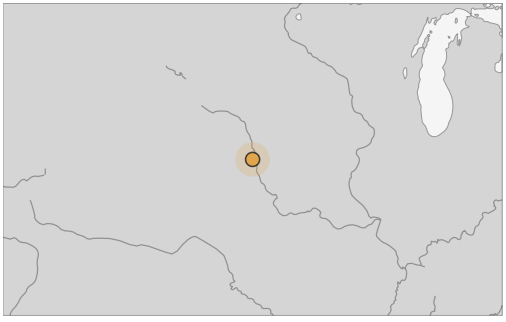
her skirt, folding wontons. The envelope went into the cash drawer that night. Kawika gave it to the Relay. Kale never asked about it, and he never did get the Travis Scotts, and by the next spring there was a pair of Dale Petersen's old leather work gloves on the shelf in his closet where the boxes had been.

Background

The verse

> *Better than sovereignty over the earth, better than going to heaven, better than lordship over all worlds, is the reward of the first step in holiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 178, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Kāla, the son of the great donor Anāthapiṇḍika, cares nothing for the Buddha and will not even come out to see him when he visits the house. His father, afraid for him, decides that anyone can be won with gifts, and promises him a hundred coins to keep the observance day at the monastery. Kāla goes, sleeps the night away, and the next morning refuses to eat until he is paid. Then his father offers him a thousand coins to learn a single verse from the Buddha. Each time Kāla thinks he has the verse, the Buddha lets him misunderstand it, so he stays to learn the next, and listening that way, with his whole attention, he enters the stream. The next day he walks home among the monks and is ashamed when his father sets the thousand coins in front of him in the Buddha's presence, and refuses them; the Buddha explains with this verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Anāthapiṇḍika. The hymn is Isaac Watts's "Crucifixion to the World by the Cross of Christ" (1707), whose fourth stanza Watts printed in brackets as one that could be left out.



Papillion, Nebraska

Papillion, Nebraska, 2019

Relay For Life began in May 1985 in Tacoma, Washington, when a surgeon, Gordon Klatt, walked and ran around a track for twenty-four hours to raise money for the American Cancer Society. The overnight events that grew from it have teams camping around a track, a survivors' lap, and a luminaria ceremony at sunset, with candles in decorated paper bags set around the track to honor survivors and the dead. Papillion lies just west of Offutt Air Force Base, a third of which was flooded when the Missouri River rose in March 2019.

By 2019 sneaker reselling had become a market of its own. StockX, launched in 2016 with stock-market-style price histories for each shoe, was valued at a billion dollars that June. The Travis Scott Air Jordan 1, released on May 11, 2019 at $175, sold out in hours, and resellers were soon asking more than $1,000.

After the story of Kāla, son of Anāthapiṇḍika, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 178). The original. Scripture from Isaac Watts, Hymns and Spiritual Songs (1707). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 14

The Buddha

14.1

One Footprint

Keep thou thy horses, keep dance and song for thyself.
— Katha Upanishad 1:26

Ī vidhaṅgā nēnu vinnānu, on the cul-de-sacs off Eldorado Parkway.

I. The Fire

Frisco, Texas · October 2004

Gopalakrishna Sarma lit his fire every morning a few minutes before sunrise, and for six years he lit it on the back patio, until the homeowners' association sent the third letter. The first letter said *open burning*. The second said *a neighbor has expressed concern regarding odor*. The third had a fine in it, a hundred and fifty dollars, and a photograph of his own backyard taken from somebody's upstairs window.

So he carried the fire to the end of the street. Past the last cul-de-sac the builder had graded the land for Phase Four, poured the streets and the sidewalks and set the fire hydrants, and then stopped to wait for the market. There were no houses yet. There were curbs that went around nothing, and street signs with names on them, Calder Court and Bandera Way, standing over black clay and Johnson grass. Every morning in the blue dark Sarma walked out there in his white dhoti and a Texas Instruments windbreaker, with a copper pot shaped like an upside-down pyramid in one hand and a tote bag from Patel Brothers in the other, and set the pot down on the bare ground where the corner lot of Calder Court would one day be.

He laid the dried cakes of cow dung in it, the ones the Indian grocery sold in plastic sleeves for the pujas, and dabbed them with ghee and lit them. He had printed the sunrise times for the whole year from a website

and kept the page folded in his wallet. At the minute the sun cleared the tree line along Panther Creek he dropped two pinches of unbroken rice into the flame with ghee on his fingers and said the words. His father had said them every day of his life in a village on the Krishna delta, and his father's father, and nobody knew how many fathers before that. The smoke went up straight on a still morning and sideways on a windy one. Then he walked home and showered and put on khakis and drove to Richardson, where he was a director of hardware engineering at a company that had laid off a third of its people in 2001 and kept him.

He had come to College Station in 1979 with a scholarship, two suitcases and the few dollars the Reserve Bank allowed, and now he had a house with three garages and a daughter.

Her name was Madhuri and she was twenty-five, and the Telugu families from Plano to McKinney agreed she was the most beautiful girl any of them had seen on this side of the ocean. She had danced Kuchipudi since she was six, on the brass plate with a water pot on her head, at every Ugadi and every Diwali in every rented school auditorium in Collin County. She was a pharmacist at a hospital in Plano. The proposals had been coming since she was nineteen. They came as envelopes from aunties in Hyderabad with a photograph and a horoscope inside, as phone calls from friends of friends in New Jersey, as printouts from the matrimony websites that her mother read at the kitchen counter with her reading glasses on her head.

Sarma said no to all of them. A cardiologist in Houston: Niyogi, not Vaidiki, and the family ate onions on Ekadashi. An engineer at Microsoft: Redmond was too far, too cold, and his father had married twice. A boy with a Stanford degree whose father owned three cinema halls in Vijayawada: *cinema halls,* Sarma said, and that was the end of that. A boy from their own district, from a good family, with a green card and a house in Irving: Sarma looked at the photograph for a long time and said the boy's chin was weak. He said the same words about each of them. He folded each biodata in thirds and laid it in a drawer of the desk in his study, and the drawer was full.

Not good enough for her.

On a cold morning in late October, with Bush–Cheney signs still standing in half the yards on Eldorado Parkway, a man came walking along the empty sidewalk of Phase Four from the direction of the highway, at the hour when nobody in that town walked anywhere.

He was thin and brown and perhaps forty, in a grey sweatshirt and old running shoes, with a canvas pack on his back and a steel bowl tied to the pack with a shoelace. He stopped a little way off from the fire, not too close, and stood with his hands at his sides and watched. He did not shift his weight. Sarma finished the words and dropped the rice and the ghee hissed, and the man was still standing there, and something in the way he stood made Sarma, who had stood before very important men in his life, want to get up off his heels.

You are Telugu, Sarma said in Telugu. He could tell from the face. Everybody could always tell.

My people are from Guntur, the man said. His Telugu was a Houston boy's, careful, with English underneath it. *I grew up in Houston. Lately I'm not from anywhere.*

Sarma looked at him. He looked at the hands, which were long and very clean though the man had plainly slept outdoors, and at the shoulders and the eyes and the stillness. He thought that in twenty-five years in America he had not seen a man like this one, and in India not either, and that this was what he had been waiting for. He did not ask the man's gotram. He did not ask what his father did. It would occur to him later that it was the first time in six years that he had not asked a single question.

I have one daughter, he said. *Only one. I have looked for a man for her for six years and I have not found one good enough. You are good enough. I want to give her to you. Wait here, right here, and I'll bring her.*

The man listened to all of it. He did not say yes and he did not say no.

II. The Footprint

Calder Court · the same morning

VASUNDHARA WAS AT THE STOVE BOILING MILK FOR COFFEE when her husband came in through the garage still in his dhoti, which he had never done, and said he had found him.

Found who?

The one. For Madhuri. He's standing at the end of the street. Wake her up.

Madhuri had worked until midnight and came down the stairs in a T-shirt from the University of Texas with her hair over her face, and her father told her to put on the Dharmavaram silk, the mango-yellow one with the green border that she had worn for her cousin's wedding, and the gold, and to hurry. She laughed at him. Then she saw that he was serious and stopped laughing, and because she was twenty-five and curious and a little afraid of him, she went and put it on. Her mother put on a cotton sari and a cardigan over it. Sarma did not change at all.

It was a quarter past seven. On that street at a quarter past seven the aunties were out in their sneakers doing their morning walk in pairs, and Reddy uncle from the corner house was in his driveway in a bathrobe picking up the *Dallas Morning News*, and the children were at the corner with their backpacks waiting for the bus, and every one of them saw the Sarmas go by. They saw Madhuri in yellow silk and gold at seven in the morning, holding her pleats up off the sidewalk, and Sarma in front of her walking very fast in his dhoti. Nobody had to ask. By the time the Sarmas reached the end of the street there were thirty people behind them, the walking aunties and Reddy uncle in his bathrobe and two grandmothers visiting from India for the winter and Mrs. Halvorsen from across the street with her dachshund, and half the children, because the bus was late. A concrete crew was unloading at the far end of Phase Four, and the men stopped unloading to watch them come.

The fire had burned down in the copper pot to grey ash with a little red under it. Nobody was there.

Where is he? said Vasundhara.

I told him to wait right here. Sarma turned all the way around, once. Then he pointed down at the sidewalk. *There. That's him. That's where he was standing.*

In the concrete of the sidewalk, a few feet from the fire, there was a footprint. A bare right foot, a man's, pressed a half-inch deep, every toe and the ball and the arch and the heel, as clean as if someone had set it there with a mold.

The foreman of the concrete crew came over to see what everyone was looking at. He was a short heavy man named Rubén with a tape measure on his belt. He crouched and pressed his thumb on the edge of the print and then knocked on it with his knuckle. *That's August,* he said. *We poured that in August. That's been hard two months.* He looked up at them. *Nobody steps in that.*

The children wanted to put their own feet in it, and their mothers held them back.

Vasundhara bent down, holding the end of her sari against her chest, and looked at the footprint for a long time.

Her grandmother in Bapatla had read feet. When there was a marriage being arranged in the family, the old woman would ask to see the boy walk across the swept courtyard in the morning, and afterward she would look at the dust and say what kind of man he was. She had taught Vasundhara a little of it on the back step, when Vasundhara was a girl, the way you teach a girl to tell good tamarind from bad, and Vasundhara had not thought about it in thirty years.

This is not a man who wants anything, she said.

Vasu.

Look at it. My grandmother used to say, a man full of wanting walks on his toes, because he's always reaching for what's in front of him. You'd see the toes deep and the heel light. An angry man comes down hard on his heels. A confused man drags his feet, you can see where he slid. This one, she said, and touched the edge of it with one finger, *put the whole foot down even and lifted it clean. Nothing pulling it forward, nothing holding it back. This is the foot of someone who has put everything down.*

Sarma made the noise he always made. For thirty years he had made the same joke to her out of the books he had learned as a boy, about the man in the dark who sees a coil of rope on the path and takes it for a snake.

You see a snake in every rope. I told him I would give him our daughter and he agreed.

He said yes?

He didn't say no.

Emandi, say what you like, she said, and stood up. *That is not the foot of a man who wants a wife.*

Don't chatter, he said. *Come with me and be quiet.*

They found him a few hundred yards on, where Bandera Way ran out at the retention pond the builder had dug for the runoff. There was a fountain in the middle of the pond that had not been turned on yet, and a sign that said NO SWIMMING NO FISHING, and the man was sitting on the concrete headwall with his pack beside him and his hands in his lap, looking at the water.

There, Sarma said, and went to him with the whole street behind him. *Sir. Here she is. I am giving you my daughter.*

The man looked at Sarma, and at Vasundhara, and for a moment at Madhuri in her yellow silk with the gold at her throat, and at the thirty people and the dachshund. Then he looked back at Sarma.

Sarma garu, he said. *Before you say that again, there's something I want to tell you. Will you listen to it?*

Tell it, said Sarma. *I'm listening.*

III. The Gate

Richardson, Texas · March 1998

His name was Kiran Vemuri. He had been born in Houston in 1964 to a doctor from Guntur and a mother who taught him the Telugu alphabet at the kitchen table on Saturday mornings, and his grandfather, visiting for a winter when Kiran was nine, had made him learn the story of the boy Nachiketas, who went to the house of Death

AND WOULD NOT GO HOME WITHOUT AN ANSWER. KIRAN HAD studied electrical engineering at UT Austin. In 1993, with a friend from school named Danny Ochoa, he had started a company in a strip of offices off Campbell Road in Richardson that made switches for fiber-optic lines, the glass threads the whole world's telephone calls were starting to go through. They called it Ninefold. By 1998 it had two hundred and forty employees and offices in three countries, and in the second week of March the bankers in New York set the date for the public offering.

Seven days. He worked it out on a legal pad one night, alone on the fourth floor. On the day the shares went on sale, on paper, he would be worth more than every person he had grown up with in Houston put together.

He had seen some things that winter. In January he had flown to Houston and sat with his father, who did not know him anymore and asked him politely what he did for a living. In February the head of sales, a man of forty-one with two little girls, had died at his desk on a Tuesday afternoon with his phone in his hand, and nobody noticed for an hour. At the funeral, in a big Methodist church in Plano, Kiran looked at all the people in their good coats and could not make it make sense. And driving home late one night on the Tollway he had seen a man walking on the shoulder in the rain with nothing in his hands and nothing on his back, not hurrying, and had watched him in the mirror until he was gone. It was the only time in years he had wanted to trade places with anybody.

At three in the morning, six nights before the offering, he called Danny at home and asked him to come get him at the office and drive him somewhere.

Danny came in his old Camry, in sweatpants. The garage under the building was empty and the lights hummed. At the exit the gate arm was down, and there was a man in the booth, though there was never anybody in the booth at that hour. The man was in a grey suit, a very good one, and when the Camry pulled up he slid the window open and leaned out with his forearms on the sill, the way a man leans on a fence to talk to a neighbor.

Go back upstairs, Kiran, he said. *Seven days. Seven days from now you're going to have everything. You know that.*

I know it, Kiran said. *I don't want it.*

Then where are you going at three in the morning?

To find out.

Find out what?

All of it, Kiran said.

The man looked at him a long time. Then he reached down and the gate arm went up.

Go on, then, he said. *But I'll tell you something. The first time you want something, anything, I'm going to know about it. And I'll be right there.*

Danny drove south. He drove through Dallas and out past the last of the lights, and somewhere south of Waxahachie Kiran asked him to pull over. On the shoulder he gave Danny his watch and his wallet and his phone and the keys to his condo and a letter for the lawyers, signing his shares over to the company's employees in equal parts, from the receptionist up. Danny cried and begged him and said he was having a breakdown and that they could get him help, and Kiran held Danny's head against his own shoulder for a minute, the way you hold a child's, and then got out and walked.

Danny drove the Camry home. He told people for years that it never ran right after that, that it was broken-hearted, and he sold it that summer for three hundred dollars.

The offering went ahead. Ninefold closed its first day at forty-one dollars a share and two years later touched ninety, and the receptionist bought a house. Then the bubble broke, and by the end of 2001 the stock was worth less than a dollar. Kiran was on foot by then, in the west.

IV. Seven Years

The Edwards Plateau · 1998–2004

The man in the grey suit kept his word. He followed Kiran for seven years.

He was at the counter of a truck stop outside Brownwood in the first summer, eating pie, and he slid a business card down the counter: a firm in Austin that wanted Kiran to run its engineering for any salary he named. He was in the parking lot of a motel in San Angelo the next winter, leaning on a white Lincoln, with a cousin from Guntur Kiran had not seen since childhood who wanted to talk about a girl. He was at a feed store in Sonora. He was on the radio. Once, outside Ozona, in the August heat, he was nothing but a cold bottle of Coca-Cola standing by itself on a fence post with the sweat running down it. Every time, he was waiting for Kiran to want something. Every time, Kiran walked on.

In those years Kiran was very hard on himself. Nobody made him. He thought that was the road. He slept in a borrowed deer blind in Sutton County through one whole winter. He picked pecans, and cleared cedar for ranchers for the price of a meal, and then stopped taking the meal, and then ate one handful of rice a day, and then a handful every other day. He sat in the sun on the limestone until the skin of his face cracked. Sheriff's deputies stopped him on the farm roads, a brown man with a pack in the years after the towers fell, and asked him for identification he did not have, and some of them were kind and some were not, and he sat in the backs of their cars and in their holding cells without complaint until they let him go. By the spring of 2004 he weighed ninety-eight pounds. He could count his own ribs from across a room. His hair came out in his hand.

He fell down one April morning by a fence on a goat ranch outside Rocksprings and could not get up.

The ranch belonged to a widow named Graciela Tijerina, who ran Angora goats for mohair on fourteen hundred acres of rock and live oak, and when she found him by her fence she thought at first he was dead. She went back to the house and came out with arroz con leche in a Cool Whip tub, still warm, with a cinnamon stick in it, and a plastic spoon, and fed him with her own hand. He ate it. It was the first full meal he had eaten in two years, and he felt the strength go down into his arms and legs like water into a dry tank.

Out on Highway 55 the man in the grey suit saw it from the shoulder and laughed out loud. *There,* he said. *There it is.* He thought Kiran had given up.

But that was only hunger. Hunger is a different thing.

Below Mrs. Tijerina's house there was a live oak older than Texas, so wide that the whole herd lay down in its shade in the afternoons. Kiran went and sat under it with his back against the trunk. He sat there all that day and all that night, and the goats came and lay down around him and got up and went and came back, and toward morning, with the sky going grey over the plateau and a mockingbird starting up in the cedar, something that had been running in him his whole life finished running. He would never be able to say it any better than that. It stopped, the way a motor stops. He sat under the tree for seven more days, and Mrs. Tijerina brought him a plate every noon, and did not ask him anything, and he ate what she brought.

On the shoulder of Highway 55 the man in the grey suit sat down on the guardrail with his tie pulled loose. He had followed for seven years and found nothing to take hold of, not one thing, and now there was nothing left to follow. He picked up a stick and drew lines in the gravel with it, one line and then another one beside it, and rubbed them out with his shoe and drew them again.

V. Three Sisters

Edwards County · April 2004

HE HAD THREE DAUGHTERS.

Kiran told Sarma their names and what the names meant. One was called Thirst. One was called Restless. One was called Heat. They came along the highway in a white car with the windows down, and when they saw their father sitting on the guardrail they pulled onto the shoulder in a spray of gravel and got out.

Daddy, what's the matter with you? Why do you look like that?

He told them. Seven years, and the man under the tree, and not one thing.

Oh, Daddy, they said. *Don't you worry about it. We'll go get him and bring him to you.*

You can't. Nobody can bring that one anywhere.

Daddy. We're women, they said. *Leave him to us.*

They came down through the goats to the live oak and stood in front of him in their summer dresses. *Let us take care of you,* they said. *We'll be yours. We'll cook for you, we'll keep house for you, we'll do whatever you say. You'll never have to want for anything.*

Kiran did not answer them. He did not open his eyes.

They went off a little way and talked it over. *Men like different things,* said Thirst. *Some like a young girl. Some like a woman. Some like them older. Let's give him all of it and see.*

So they came back. Graciela Tijerina saw them from her kitchen window and told it afterward at the Catholic church in Rocksprings, and some people believed her and some did not, and she said she did not care which. She said they came up from the highway in a crowd, too many to count, a hundred and then another hundred, women of every age there is. They came first as girls of sixteen in cutoff jeans. They came as young brides who had never had a baby, with their wedding rings on. They came as young mothers with one baby on the hip, and then with two children by the hand. They came as women of fifty in reading glasses carrying covered dishes, and last of all as old women, white-haired, slow, leaning on canes. Six times they came down through the goats to the tree, and every time they knelt in front of the man sitting under it and said the same thing. *Let us take care of you. We'll be yours.*

He did not open his eyes. He told Sarma he did not need to.

But they would not go away, and finally he opened his eyes and looked at them, all of them, and he said, *Go on home. What are you looking at me for? Go find somebody who still wants something. You can't catch hold of a man who's let go of everything. There's nothing on him to hold.*

And then he said to them, he told Sarma, what the boy said to Death in the old story, when Death offered him herds and gold and the whole wide earth, and beautiful women with chariots and music, if he would only stop asking.

> *These things last till to-morrow, O Death, for they wear out this vigour of all the senses. Even the whole of life is short. Keep thou thy horses, keep dance and song for thyself.*
>
> *— Katha Upanishad 1:26*

Sarma's lips had been moving for a while. He had learned the Katha by heart at twelve in his father's house, in Sanskrit, sitting cross-legged on a mat, and he had chanted it at a thousand ceremonies since, and he went on with it now without meaning to, out loud, the verses from near the end where the teaching stops. He said them in Sanskrit and then, because the walking aunties and Reddy uncle and the children and Mrs. Halvorsen were all looking at him, he said them again in English the way he had first read them as a student, in the old Oxford translation, in the library at College Station, in another life.

> *When all desires that dwell in his heart cease, then the mortal becomes immortal, and obtains Brahman. When all the ties of the heart are severed here on earth, then the mortal becomes immortal—here ends the teaching.*
>
> *— Katha Upanishad 6:14–15*

He stopped. He had said those words, he thought, ten thousand times. He was hearing them now for the first time.

Mrs. Tijerina said that when she looked out the window again, the women were gone. All of them, every age, and no car on the highway in either direction as far as she could see, and no man sitting on the guardrail. She said the goats were lying down around the tree as if nothing had happened, and the dogs were asleep on the porch, and the whole ranch was quieter than she had ever heard it, so quiet she could hear the windmill turning on the far side of the hill. She said she knew then she had been feeding somebody, she was not sure who.

VI. The Sole of the Foot

The retention pond · the same morning

Kiran was quiet for a moment. The fountain in the pond was not running. Somebody's sprinklers had come on behind them, ticking.

Sarma garu, he said. *When those three came to me, they looked like gold. They looked like nothing you ever saw. And I didn't want them, not for one second.* He looked at Madhuri. He did not look at her unkindly. He looked at her the way the foreman had looked at the footprint. *Your daughter is beautiful. Everybody here can see that. But a body is a bag. It's skin over what's in a body. Blood and bile and phlegm and what the bowels carry, all of it. If my foot were dirty and she were lying across my doorway, I would not touch her with the sole of it.*

Every Telugu person at that pond drew in a breath at the same time. You do not touch a person with your foot. A child learns it before it can walk. If your foot so much as brushes someone by accident on a crowded bus, you touch their arm and then your own eyes, to take it back. Two of the aunties put their hands over their mouths. One of the grandmothers visiting from India began, very quietly, to pray.

Vasundhara looked at her daughter.

Madhuri had gone perfectly still. Her face did not change, and that was how her mother knew. It went still the way milk goes still in the pan just before it turns. She stood in her yellow silk with her mother's gold at her throat and looked at the man on the headwall, and then she gathered her pleats up off the concrete in one hand and turned and walked back up Bandera Way alone, through the crowd, which parted for her. When she came to the footprint in the sidewalk she did not step on it. She stepped around it, wide, as if it were a hole.

Sarma sat down on the headwall beside the man. He sat down heavily, like somebody whose legs had been taken out from under him, in his dhoti and his windbreaker with the ghee still shining on his fingers, and he did not say anything for a long time. Vasundhara watched him. She had been married to him for twenty-seven years. She had watched him at

a hundred kitchen tables turn a stranger's photograph to the light and look for what was wrong with it. She watched his face now and saw that he was not looking for anything.

Something opened in her too, standing there. She could not have said what. She thought of her grandmother on the back step in Bapatla, reading the dust. A whole foot set down even and lifted clean.

Kiran picked up his pack and put it on. He touched Sarma once on the shoulder. Then he walked out along the edge of the pond to where the frontage road ran south, and down the frontage road, not hurrying, and the people of Calder Court watched him go until the light came up behind the billboards and they could not see him anymore.

VII. Phase Four

Frisco · 2005–2011

Madhuri asked her mother's brother in Edison, New Jersey, to find her a husband, and he did it in five months. She married a man in Saratoga, California, who had sold a software company to a bigger one for more money than any boy her father had ever turned down, and the wedding was at a hotel in San Jose with eleven hundred guests and two priests flown in from Tirupati. Her father gave her away and wept. She never came home to Frisco again without asking her mother on the phone, first, in a voice that was very light, whether that man had been seen. She kept what he had said the way some people keep a coin from a country they will never go back to, in a drawer, and take it out and turn it over.

Sarma retired the next spring. He lit his fire every morning until the end, at the end of the street, but those who walked past said he did it differently. He did it the way you rinse a cup. In 2006 the market came back and the builder came back with it, and the first slab went down for a house on the corner lot of Calder Court, right where he had kept his fire, and that week he sold the big house on the cul-de-sac. He and Vasundhara gave away most of what was in it. He fed the drawer full of biodatas into a shredder, one by one. Then they went back to his father's village on

the Krishna delta and lived there in two rooms by the canal, the way the old books say people should when their children are grown, at the edge of things. Vasundhara wrote to her friends in Frisco for a few years. In the last letter anybody remembers she said that Emandi had stopped telling her she saw snakes in ropes, and that neither of them saw much of anything in anything anymore, and that it was very peaceful.

Phase Four filled in. By 2011 there were brick houses on every lot, with live oaks staked in the yards, and a family from Lagos on the corner of Calder Court and a family from Ohio next door, and the fountain in the pond ran all day. The builder had wanted to grind the footprint out of the sidewalk before the houses sold, and then a man from the homeowners' association wanted to, and in the end nobody did.

The children of Phase Four still put their feet in it, on the way to the bus. It is the first thing a new child on that street is shown. Every one of them tries it, left foot and then right, and their fathers try it, and nobody's foot has ever fit. After a rain it holds water, and you can stand over it and see the sky in it, and your own face.

There is only the one. People have walked that whole sidewalk looking, and all the sidewalks after it, out to the frontage road. Nobody has ever found the next.

Background

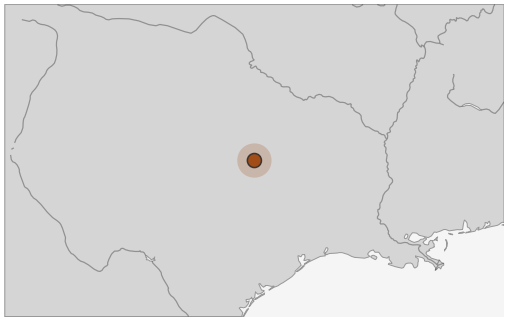
The verses

> *He whose conquest is not conquered again, into whose conquest no one in this world enters, by what track can you lead him, the Awakened, the Omniscient, the trackless?*
>
> Dhammapada 179, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He whom no desire with its snares and poisons can lead astray, by what track can you lead him, the Awakened, the Omniscient, the trackless?*
>
> Dhammapada 180, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin named Māgandiya refuses every suitor for his beautiful daughter as not good enough. One morning, at the place where he tends his sacred fire, he meets the Buddha and offers her to him, and runs home to fetch her.

When the family returns with a crowd behind them, the Buddha has moved on, leaving a single footprint. The Brahmin's wife, who knows the lore of bodily signs, reads it as the foot of a man free of desire; her husband tells her she sees a crocodile in a drop of water. When they find him, the Buddha tells the story of his Great Renunciation: how Māra met him at the city gate and promised him a world empire in seven days, followed him for seven years, and at last sat defeated by the road, until his three daughters, Taṇhā, Aratī and Ragā (Craving, Discontent and Lust), came to tempt the Buddha in the forms of women of every age. He sends them away with these two verses. Then he tells the Brahmin that he would not touch his daughter's body even with his foot, a remark the daughter never forgives. Read the full commentary story, or about Māra and his daughters.



Frisco, Texas

North Texas and the Edwards Plateau, 1998–2004

Frisco, north of Dallas, was the fastest-growing city in the United States from 2000 to 2009, as subdivisions spread north from Plano onto blackland prairie. It grew as a bedroom community for professionals who worked across the Dallas–Fort Worth area. Telugu Americans, from Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, came first as students, doctors and scientists, and then, from the late 1980s, in a large wave of software engineers that grew around the turn of the century. The dot-com bubble that made and unmade fortunes in those years peaked in March 2000; by October 2002 the Nasdaq had lost 78 percent of its value, and many telecommunications companies went under with it. Sarma's morning fire is the agnihotra, the Vedic offering of ghee into the fire at sunrise and sunset, which the heads of Brahmin households were once obliged to make every day. Vasundhara's grandmother practices Sāmudrika Śāstra, the old Indian lore of reading character and fate from the marks of the body.

The Katha Upanishad tells of the boy Nachiketas, who goes to the house of Death and asks what happens after dying. Death tries to buy him off with herds, gold, long life, a kingdom and beautiful women, and the boy refuses all of it. The verses here are from F. Max Müller's translation in volume 15 of the Sacred Books of the East

(1884); Müller numbered the Upanishad's six sections straight through, so his "6, 14" is often cited elsewhere as 2.3.14. Kiran's ranch is on the Edwards Plateau near Rocksprings, the seat of Edwards County, named for the springs in its limestone, which calls itself the Angora goat capital of the world.

After the story of Māgandiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 179–180). The original. Scripture from the Katha Upanishad, tr. F. Max Müller, *The Upanishads, Part II* (Sacred Books of the East 15, 1884). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

14.2

Three Ladders

> *Surely I have behaved and quieted myself, as a child that is weaned of his mother.*
> *— Psalm 131:2*

This is how I hear it, on Lenox Avenue.

I. The Bowl

Harlem · spring 1927

Cyril Pemberton ran the biggest policy bank north of 125th Street, and every morning from May until the first frost he swam in the Harlem River, the way he had swum off the bay in Basseterre as a boy. His driver brought him down to the water at six with a wicker hamper, and he put his watch and his diamond stickpin and his good suit in the hamper so they would not walk off while he was in the water, and the driver sat on the hamper and smoked.

One morning in April a block of wood came down the river on the tide and fetched up against the hamper and stayed there. It was about the size of a coal scuttle, worn round by the water, slick with weed. Pemberton came out dripping and turned it over with his foot and had the driver scrape it with his penknife, and under the weed it was red. Mahogany, Honduras mahogany, red as a cut plum, off some lighter or some barge that had broken up in the Bronx Kills.

Pemberton was not a churchman and not a heathen. He had money in four churches and a gold tooth he said was for luck, and he did not believe in luck. He stood there on the rocks in his drawers and thought.

Every corner in Harlem had a holy man on it. There were bishops in storefronts and prophets over barbershops, and mystics in turbans who

read your number in a glass of water for fifty cents, and a man on 131st Street who said he was God and had cards printed. Pemberton had listened to all of them. He had paid most of them. He had never once met a man he believed.

He took the wood to a cabinetmaker on Lenox Avenue and had it turned on the lathe into a bowl, the size you would put rice in, polished till it glowed. Then he had his men lash scaffold poles end to end, up and up, ninety feet, and stay them with cables over the corner of 135th Street and Lenox, and at the top they hung the bowl on a cord. And he put a notice in the Amsterdam News.

If there is a holy man in Harlem, let him fly up and take it down. Whoever does it, I will follow him, and my wife, and my house.

The holy men came. There were six of them who mattered. Bishop Graves of the Temple of the Cosmic Fire, and Mother Hattie of the Spiritual Science Church, and a man called Professor Aziz who said he had studied in India, and Elder Purcell, and Daddy Joy, and the one with the cards. They came one at a time to Pemberton's office over the cigar store and said the same thing in different words. That bowl is just the thing for me. Do not insist that a man of God make a show of himself for a wooden dish. Give it here.

Fly up and take it, Pemberton said.

On the sixth day Bishop Graves came himself, with his people. He went out into the middle of Lenox Avenue under the poles and lifted one hand and one foot, slowly, like a heron, and before the foot was off the ground his deacons had him by the arms and the coattails. *Bishop, Bishop, what are you doing? You will not show them the power of God for a piece of wood.* And they pulled him down and laid him on the asphalt, gently, and he lay there and said to Pemberton, *You see, my people will not allow it. Give me the bowl.*

Fly up and take it, said Pemberton.

On the seventh morning two men of Mr. Thorne's came out of the subway at 125th Street. Clement Mayers was a stevedore on the Hudson piers, a quiet thick-shouldered man from St. Lucy, and Pindar Bascombe was a Pullman porter with a laugh you could hear across a rail yard. They

had stopped at the big rock in Mount Morris Park, the old hill of black stone with the fire tower on top, so Pindar could change his porter's jacket for his own coat, and while he did it some loafers on the bench below were talking.

Seven days that bowl's been hanging. Every saint in Harlem's had a go. Well, now we know. There's no such thing.

Clement looked at Pindar. *You hear them. You go.*

You go. You're the strong one.

You go, said Clement.

So Pindar went into himself the way Mr. Thorne had taught them, quiet, down to the bottom, and came up again, and then he put the toe of his shoe against the rock of Mount Morris and drew a line around it, and lifted it. The whole hill. Fire tower, bell and all, as easy as a man lifts a hat. He carried it up into the air over Harlem and walked it around seven times, east to the river and west to the bluff, so that the rock hung over the town like a lid on a pot. People on Lenox Avenue looked up and screamed and put washtubs over their heads and crawled under the stoops. On the seventh time around, Pindar broke a hole in the rock with his heel and put his head through so they could see him, laughing, and they all cried out, *Pindar! Hold it, man, hold it, don't drop it on us!* And he kicked it away from him, back to the park, where it settled in its place so neatly that the bell in the tower only rang once. Then he came down on the roof of Cyril Pemberton's house on 139th Street, and took the bowl.

Pemberton came up through the roof hatch in his dressing gown. He went down on his face on the tar. *Master, come down.* And when Pindar came down, Pemberton took him into the kitchen and filled the bowl with sugar cake, guava cheese, condensed milk and honey, and gave it back to him. Pindar walked off up Lenox Avenue with it, and everybody who had been under a washtub and missed it ran after him, *Do it again, do it again,* and he laughed, and did it again.

Mr. Thorne was walking up from 125th Street with Ernest, the boy who carried his parcels, when he heard the roaring.

What are they cheering, Ernest?

Ernest told him.

Mr. Thorne sent for Pindar. He did not raise his voice; he never did. He asked him was it true, and Pindar said yes, and Mr. Thorne asked him why, and Pindar had nothing to say. Then Mr. Thorne took the bowl out of his hands and gave him a hatchet and told him to split it, there on the stoop, into kindling, and give the kindling to the old women on the block for their stoves. And he told all of them who walked with him, there were perhaps forty that year, that none of them was ever to do such a thing again for anybody to look at.

II. The Peach Tree

Harlem · spring and summer, 1927

Josiah Thorne had been a ship's carpenter out of Bridgetown, Barbados, forty years, on schooners and then on the big steamers of the Royal Mail, until his eyes went too far for fine work. He was past seventy. He had a room on 133rd Street and worshipped at the West Indian Episcopal church on Sundays at the back, and the rest of the week he sat on his stoop, or walked, and men came and sat on the steps below him, and some of them came back. He did not preach. He did not take collections or print cards. He talked when he was asked, briefly, and spent a good deal of time sitting very still, which the children on 133rd Street tried to imitate and could not.

When the holy men heard that he had made his people split the bowl, they were glad. *Now we have him,* they said. *His men won't break his rule, and he won't break it either.* And they went up and down Lenox Avenue with a bass drum telling everybody that they had kept their powers hidden out of modesty, and that Thorne's people had made a show of themselves for a dish, and that from now on they would work wonders against nobody but Thorne himself.

The district leader heard it. His name was Royall, and he gave out the turkeys at Thanksgiving and the coal in February and the jobs at the Department of Sanitation, and there was not much in Harlem he did not hear. He came to 133rd Street in his car and sat on the stoop beside Mr. Thorne in his good coat.

They tell me you've made a rule. No miracles.

Yes.

And the bishop says now he'll match you, wonder for wonder.

If he does, I will too.

But it's your rule.

It's my rule for them. I didn't make it for me.

Royall laughed. *That's a fine rule. A rule for everybody but the man that made it.*

Mr. Thorne looked at him. *You have a peach tree,* he said. *In the yard behind your house on 139th Street. I've seen it over the wall.*

I do.

If the boys on the block climb your wall and eat your peaches, what do you do?

I call the precinct.

And when you eat them yourself?

They're my peaches.

Well, said Mr. Thorne. That was all he said about it. Royall sat a while longer, and then asked him when, and where. Mr. Thorne said four months from now, on the full moon in July, and he would do it uptown, at the top of the hill, so there would be room for everybody.

The holy men followed him after that. Wherever Mr. Thorne ate his supper, they slept the night; wherever he slept, they took their breakfast. When people asked what they were doing, they said, *He said he'd meet us and now he's running. We won't let him get away.* In July they hired a tent from a revival outfit in Newark and put it up on a vacant lot on St. Nicholas Avenue, and covered the poles with blue cornflowers from the market, and sat under it in a row and said, *Here. Here is where it will be done.*

Royall came again. *They've put up a tent. Let me put one up for you.*

I have a builder.

Who? There's nobody in Harlem can put up a tent but me.

Mr. Thorne pointed up with one finger, and did not explain.

Where will you do it? Royall asked.

At the foot of the fruit man's tree.

The holy men heard that and sent their people out the same night with saws and spades. They cut down every tree for a mile around, every ailanthus in every back yard, every young plane tree the city had planted along the avenues with a little iron fence around it, and they pulled the geraniums out of the window boxes and the seedlings out of the lard tins on the fire escapes, where West Indian women grew peppers and mango seedlings from home, and they threw it all in the river.

III. The Mango

St. Nicholas Avenue · the full moon of July

THAT MORNING A GRENADIAN NAMED GANT, WHO HAD A PUSHcart of fruit on Lenox Avenue, found one perfect mango in a crate off the banana boat from Kingston. It was a Julie mango, the kind that goes from green to gold to red at the shoulder, and it was ripe, and the smell came off it so that the flies followed his cart. He wrapped it in tissue paper and set out with it to Royall's house. Royall would give him a dollar for it, maybe two.

On the way he met Mr. Thorne walking with Ernest. He stood there with the mango in his hands. A dollar or two, he thought. That will not keep me alive past Tuesday. And he held it out.

Mr. Thorne looked at Ernest. Ernest took the tissue paper off and put the mango in Mr. Thorne's hands, and Mr. Thorne sat down on the stone curb of the vacant lot at the top of St. Nicholas Avenue, across from the holy men's tent. Ernest borrowed a glass from a soda fountain and squeezed the mango into it with water and a sliver of ice from the iceman's cart, and Mr. Thorne drank it.

Dig a hole here, Mr. Gant, he said, *and plant the seed.*

Gant scratched a hole in the cinders of the lot with a piece of slate and put the seed in it. Mr. Thorne poured the last of the water over his hands into the hole.

The tree came up while they watched. It came up the thickness of a lamppost, and then a telegraph pole, sixty, seventy feet, and put out five great limbs, four to the four corners of the street and one straight up, and

it leafed out dark and shining and came into flower and then into fruit, all in the time it takes to say it, and on one side the fruit was already ripe and falling. Mr. Thorne's men ate the mangoes standing in the lot with the juice running down to their elbows. Royall heard about it and sent two patrolmen to stand under it so nobody would cut it down, and it was called Gant's tree from that day.

The boys of the block ate too. Then they took the seeds and threw them at the tent across the street. *You chopped down every tree in Harlem,* they shouted, *and look here what we got.*

In the afternoon a wind came off the river. It took the holy men's tent up off its stakes like a sheet off a line and carried it east, cornflowers and all, and dropped it in the Harlem River at the mouth of the big sewer. Then the sun came out white and hot and stood still over St. Nicholas Avenue, and the holy men in their black coats and robes sat there sweating, and the wind came back and blew the dust of the lot all over them, so that they were red from head to foot, and then the rain came down in drops as big as quarters, and they were spotted like Holstein cows. They ran.

Elder Purcell ran down toward the river. On the way he met a man of his own church coming up, a coal heaver with a pail of soup for his supper and a coil of rope over his shoulder. *Elder, I'm going to see you work your wonder. Where are you going?*

What do you want with a wonder? said Elder Purcell. *Give me your pail and your rope.*

The man gave them to him. Elder Purcell went down to the end of the pier at 135th Street, and poured out the soup, and tied the pail to his neck with the rope, and filled it with river water, and went over. The coal heaver saw the bubbles come up and stop. The police dragged the river for two days. He was sixty-one and had a wife in Raleigh. The holy men buried him in Woodlawn and spoke a long time over him, and Mr. Thorne came and stood at the back, and Ernest saw that he was weeping.

IV. Not for You

The top of the hill · that evening

At dusk a path appeared in the air. It ran from the East River to the Hudson, high over 145th Street, and it shone the way the inside of an oyster shell shines, so that the people coming up the hill stopped and stood with their mouths open. By full dark there were people on every street from the river to the river, on the roofs and the fire escapes and the elevated platforms and the cliffs of St. Nicholas Park, more people than Harlem had ever held, and Mr. Thorne came out from the house where he had been resting and stood on the stoop.

Mother Gertrude came to him first. She was a laundress, a widow, sixty, and some people said she had been seen walking on the surface of the reservoir in Central Park at four in the morning. *Mr. Thorne, while you have a daughter like me, you don't need to trouble yourself. Let me. I will turn the whole island to water and go down in it like a cormorant and come up at Coney Island, and at Yonkers, and at Jersey City, and right here in the middle. People will say, who is that, and they'll say, that's only Gertrude the washerwoman, and what must he be.*

I know you can, Gertrude, he said. *This basket wasn't packed for you.*

She stepped aside. Then they came one after another. Young Mr. Inniss, the caterer, who fed half the funerals in Harlem, said he would stand up as tall as the Woolworth Building and stamp his foot and shake the island like thunder. A little girl of seven named Clara, who sang in the junior choir and had answered the bishop of New York's catechism questions at her confirmation in words that made him sit down, said she would bring the Palisades and the Catskills and Bear Mountain and set them in a row and fly over them like a gull without touching. A boy of seven named Cuthbert said he would pull up the great elm in Central Park and carry it on his shoulder and shake down fruit for everybody. Sister Lillian, an old woman who had nursed in Panama when they cut the Canal, said she would come up Seventh Avenue as the Queen of England with a regiment behind her and kneel to him in the street.

I know you can, he said, to each.

Last came Clement Mayers. *I'll crack the Palisades between my teeth like a peanut. I'll roll the island up like a rug and hold it in one hand. I'll take every soul here to Africa and bring them back before morning.*

I know you can, Clement. This one isn't yours. What I carry, nobody else carries. It's always been so. And he sat down on the stoop, because Clement looked so stricken, and told him a story.

When I was a boy in St. Philip there was an old woman kept a black ox. A carter left it with her for his rent, and she raised it on cornmeal pap like a child, and the children rode on it. One day a merchant came to the gully with a string of carts and could not get them up the far bank, not with every team he had, and the ox went down and stood by the gully till the man asked whose it was. Nobody's, they told him. So he put a rope through its nose, and it would not move a step until he said what he would pay. Then it took the carts up the bank one by one. And when the man tied half the money round its neck, the ox stood across the road in front of the first cart and would not let him pass until he tied on the rest. And it went home to the old woman with the money, so tired its eyes were red, and she washed it in warm water and cried, and said, Did I ask you to do this for me?

Clement waited.

There was another, said Mr. Thorne, *belonged to a parson in Christ Church parish, and the parson bet a planter it could pull a hundred carts of stone. And on the day, the parson sat up on the first cart and shouted at it, Pull, you wretch, pull, you worthless brute. And it planted its feet and would not move, and the parson lost his money. And the ox came home and said to him, Parson, in all my years with you did I ever break a pot? Then why call me a brute? Go bet him double. And the next time the parson said, Pull, my beauty, pull, my fine one, and it pulled all hundred carts at once.*

Who was the ox? Clement said.

Mr. Thorne got up off the step. *Speak sweet to people, Clement,* he said. *That's the whole of it.* And he went up the stairs that were not there into the air, onto the path of light over 145th Street.

What happened next was told afterward by more people than were alive in Harlem, and no two of them told it the same, but on this they all agreed. Fire came out of the top of him and water out of the bottom of

him, and then water from the top and fire from the bottom, and from his right side and his left, fire from his right eye and water from his left, from his hands, from his feet, out of every pore of him, fire and water both, and the fire did not dry the water and the water did not put out the fire. It went up out of sight and came down again over the rivers. There were colors in it that the women who sewed could not name. And while he walked, there was another of him, exactly him, in his old brown suit, standing; and when that one walked, he stood; and the other one asked him questions, out loud, the questions the crowd would have asked if they had known how, and he answered them. He did not tire anybody. He stopped often and let them breathe. Old men who had not believed in anything since the war came down off the elevated platforms and sat in the street.

V. Three Months

Mount Morris Park · summer and autumn, 1927

THEN HE WAS GONE, THE WAY THE MOON GOES BEHIND A building.

They looked for him all night. *He's gone to Brooklyn. He's gone home to Barbados. He was ashamed to do such a thing before so many people, and he's gone where nobody knows him.* Women sat on the curbs and cried. In the morning they went to Clement, who knew, and Clement said, *Ask Mr. Andrews.*

Mr. Andrews had been blind since a boiler burst in the engine room of a Royal Mail steamer in 1899, and he saw more than anybody. *He's gone up to his mother,* he said. *She died having him, in Bridgetown, in the hurricane year. He never got to tell her anything. He's telling her now. Three months. He'll come down when the summer's over and the rains are done.*

Then we'll wait, said the crowd. And they did. They camped in Mount Morris Park, on the grass and the rock, under the fire tower, with the sky for a roof, thousands of them, all summer and into the fall. The newspapers came to look and went away again. And this was a wonder too, that

there were so many and the park was never dirty. The ground took whatever they dropped.

Before he went, Mr. Thorne had told Clement to answer them, and told young Inniss to feed them. So every morning Inniss came with his wagons, oatmeal and cocoa tea and salt-fish cakes and bread, and every evening Clement sat on the rock and answered questions until the questions ran out.

Mr. Andrews told some of what went on up there, to anybody who would sit with him. That the dead from every country sat around Mr. Thorne at his mother's feet. That close at his right hand sat a dead man from Lenox Avenue nobody had thought much of, who had once poured half his own bowl of soup into Mr. Andrews' cup at a lunch counter, and far off at the back sat a rich man who had given ten thousand dollars to the churches of New York and never once looked at who he gave it to. And Mr. Thorne said to the rich man, *Why are you sitting so far away?* and the poor man said, *A little seed in good ground, Mr. Thorne. That's all.* Mr. Andrews said that while the nights lasted, Mr. Thorne talked to his mother about every thought a person can have, one after another, the good ones and the bad ones and the ones that are neither, and that she listened the way she had not been able to listen in Bridgetown. And that every day at noon he came down for his dinner, somewhere in the city, and told it to Gus Lashley, who was a doorman on Edgecombe Avenue, and Gus told it at night in the lobby to five hundred young men who had come to him after the miracle, so many that they sat up the stairwell to the fifth floor. And the young men learned it all before the summer was out. They had always had the ears for it, Mr. Andrews said. They were the boys who used to sit under the window of the Episcopal church choir practice and listen, years ago, not understanding a word, because they loved the sound.

VI. Three Ladders

Edgecombe Avenue · October 1927

Seven days before the end, the crowd went to Clement. *We will not go home till we see him. Tell us when.*

Clement went down into the ground right there in Mount Morris Park, between two rocks, and came up eight miles south at the foot of the Woolworth Building, which was then the tallest building in the world, and climbed it. He climbed the outside. All Harlem was on its roofs to watch, and they could see him from there, the way you can see a yellow thread pulled through a bead, going up the white face of it. *He's past the twentieth floor. He's past the fortieth.* At the top he went into the sky, and found Mr. Thorne, and asked him.

Where's Gus? said Mr. Thorne.

At his door on Edgecombe Avenue.

Seven days, then. At Gus's door. Tell them to fast, and come as if they were coming to church in their own parish, and not to bring anything.

On the seventh day, in the evening, three ladders came down out of the sky onto the sidewalk in front of Gus Lashley's building on Edgecombe Avenue, where the hill falls off toward the Harlem flats and you can see the whole valley. On the right was a ladder of gold, and the dead came down it, the ones Mr. Andrews had seen, in their best clothes. On the left was a ladder of silver, and a very big old man came down it with an umbrella, and all his people after him. In the middle was a ladder made of something that broke the light into colors, and Mr. Thorne came down that one, in his brown suit.

At the top, before he started down, he did it once more, the fire and the water. Then he looked up, and everybody on Edgecombe Avenue could see all the way up as far as there is. And he looked down, and they could see all the way down, which some of them never forgot. And he looked around to all sides, and they could see everybody, the living and the dead, and the living and the dead could see each other. A man with a guitar came down beside him on the right, playing, and a woman on the left threw flowers. The big old man held the umbrella over him. Some-

body fanned him with a cardboard fan from a funeral parlor on Seventh Avenue.

He set his right foot on the sidewalk first.

Gus Lashley came out of his doorway in his uniform with the brass buttons. He had held that door eleven years. He went down on his knees on the pavement.

I never saw such a thing, he said. *Nobody ever heard of such a thing. A teacher speaking so sweet, coming down out of heaven with all his company.* He was crying. *Mr. Thorne, today everybody loves you. The dead and the living. Everybody wants you.*

Mr. Thorne put his hand on Gus's shoulder and made him stand up.

That's the quiet they love, Gus, he said. *People love it when they see it on somebody.* And then, because Gus was a churchman and liked to have it from the Book, he said it the way they say it at Evensong.

> *LORD, my heart is not haughty, nor mine eyes lofty: neither do I exercise myself in great matters, or in things too high for me.*
>
> *Surely I have behaved and quieted myself, as a child that is weaned of his mother: my soul is even as a weaned child.*
>
> *— Psalm 131:1–2*

And the angels, he said, *the angels desire to look into it.*

> *which things the angels desire to look into.*
>
> *— 1 Peter 1:12*

Then he stood on the sidewalk and asked them a question. He asked it so that the newest of them could answer it, and they did. Then he asked it again, deeper, so that only those who had been sitting on the steps a year could answer, and then deeper, so that only Clement could, and then deeper still, and Clement could not. The whole of Edgecombe Avenue and the steps and the roofs and the valley below waited, the living and the dead, and nobody could answer it. *Leave it, Mr. Thorne,* somebody called. *There's nobody here can answer that.*

He looked at Gus. Gus was standing in his doorway with his face working. He understood the question. What he did not understand was why it was being asked of him, and where to begin.

Augustus, Mr. Thorne said, *what's a person?*

It was a clue, nothing more. But Gus took hold of it the way a man takes hold of a rope in the dark, and pulled, and the whole answer came up out of him, and he gave it, standing in the doorway in his uniform, and when he was done there was not a sound anywhere from the river to the river.

Then Gus laughed out loud, like a man who has found money. *Mr. Thorne,* he said, *if you asked me a thousand more like that, I could count you every drop of rain that has ever fallen on the sea, and on the land, and on the mountains, since the world began. I could count them for you and set it down in a ledger.*

Mr. Thorne smiled at him. *I know you can count, Gus,* he said.

• • •

That was the end of it, the way they tell it. The ladders went back up, and the people went home to their own beds for the first time since July, and Cyril Pemberton gave up the policy bank the next year and went into the funeral business with young Inniss, which some said was not as much of a change as he thought. Gant's tree stood on the lot on St. Nicholas Avenue until the city put up a building there, and the building had a mango tree carved over the door, and nobody inside it knew why.

The night Josiah Thorne died, in 1931, in his room on 133rd Street, the men on the steps asked him what he had gained by all of it. He said, *Nothing,* and closed his eyes. Some of them went away hurt, and said that the old man had admitted it at last. Gus explained to them, again and again, what he had meant. Some of them believed Gus. Some did not.

On Edgecombe Avenue, in front of the building where Gus held the door, there is a place in the sidewalk where the concrete is smoother than the concrete around it, about the size of a man's right shoe. The super has had it relaid twice. It comes back. Children step over it without being told.

Background

The verse

> *Even the gods envy those who are awakened and not forgetful, who are given to meditation, who are wise, and who delight in the repose of retirement (from the world).*
>
> Dhammapada 181, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary's longest story begins at Rājagaha, where a rich man hangs a red sandalwood bowl high on bamboo poles for any arahant who can fly up and take it. The rival teachers fake an attempt; the Buddha's disciple Piṇḍola Bhāradvāja lifts a great rock over the city and takes the bowl, and the Buddha has the bowl broken up and forbids his disciples such displays. When the rivals challenge him, he says the rule binds his disciples, not himself, and promises a miracle in four months at Sāvatthī. A gardener gives him the mango meant for the king; the seed becomes a great tree overnight; wind, sun, dust and rain rout the rivals, and one drowns himself. The Buddha declines his disciples' offers to work wonders in his place, tells two birth stories about a bull, and performs the Twin Miracle of fire and water. Then he goes up to the Heaven of the Thirty-Three to teach his mother for three months while the crowd camps and waits, and comes down on three ladders at the gate of Saṅkassa, where Sāriputta praises him and answers a question no one else can. Read the full commentary story, or about the Twin Miracle.

Harlem, New York

Harlem, 1927

By the 1920s Harlem was the capital of Black America, filled by the Great Migration from the South and by immigrants from the Caribbean, who by 1920 made up roughly a quarter of New York's Black population and built their own Episcopal and Methodist congregations and mutual-aid societies. Hundreds of storefront churches operated out of empty shops and basements, and in the years before the Second

World War Harlem also produced a run of flamboyant charismatic leaders, of whom Father Divine became the most famous. More on Harlem.

The numbers, or policy, made fortunes in Harlem in the 1920s. Bettors picked three digits, the winning number was taken from the published Clearing House totals, and a payoff of 600 to 1 was typical. Among the biggest bankers was Casper Holstein, born on St. Croix, who also funded Harlem Renaissance literary prizes. The rock of Mount Morris Park (now Marcus Garvey Park), a hill of Manhattan schist, still carries its cast-iron fire watchtower and bell. The Woolworth Building downtown was the tallest building in the world from 1913 to 1930.

After the story of the Twin Miracle from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 181). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

14.3

Water Coconut

> *It is most difficult to meet with this superior law, even in myriads of kotis of Æons*
> *— Saddharma-Pundarika II.135, tr. H. Kern*

Như vầy tôi nghe, on channel sixty-eight.

I. Book Five

Oak Street, Biloxi, Mississippi · Tuesday, May 12, 1987 · the fifteenth of the fourth month

I KEEP THE RADIO FOR THE BOATS. IT SITS ON THE KITCHEN counter by the window, the VHF and next to it the sideband for the big water, and beside them a school composition book and a cup of pencils. When a boat calls I write the hour, the name of the boat, and what was said. I have done it every night since 1982, when one of ours did not come home and afterward nobody on the Point could agree what day she had last called. I said then that it would be written down. So it is written down, and this is the fifth book. Where I only heard a thing I write *heard*. Where I was looking at it I write *saw*. Most nights there is nothing to see.

They call me Cô Năm. We are Catholic, from Phước Tỉnh. We went out in '78 with nineteen in the boat and landed seventeen. My husband has the *Thanh Tâm*, and tonight he is off Ship Shoal on the Louisiana side, because the Sound does not open until June and the note on the boat does not wait for June.

Tonight is the full moon of the fourth month, which the Buddhists keep for the birthday of their Buddha. I put that down so that anybody who reads this book will know I did not make the day fit.

Everybody on the Back Bay knows what happens at the fuel dock on the first and the fifteenth of the moon. Ông Bảy does not drag on those

two days. He has not dragged on one of them in four years, shrimp or no shrimp, and he is the best captain we have. The old families call him Mr. Bay, and the King, and that is only half a joke, because the Shrimp King at their Blessing is always one of their own old men and he lands more than any of them. On those two evenings he brings his boat round and anchors her off the fuel dock, out where nobody can climb on her. Her name is *Lá Dừa Nước*, leaf of the water coconut, the palm that stands in the mud along every canal at home. It is painted on her bow without the marks, and the Americans say *La Dua* and think she is named for a woman. Why a man would name a boat for a leaf, he has never said.

Then the girl climbs up on the wheelhouse roof. Ngọc is nineteen. He carried her off the boat in ’79 and signed for her in the camp on Bidong, and nobody has ever heard her call him anything but father. She sings one verse in the old way, the way girls sang across the canals to the boys in the other boats, a question that wants its answer sung back. He made the verse. And he has let it be known from Port Arthur to Bayou La Batre that the man who answers it right gets the girl, and the boat with her.

They have come from everywhere. She told my daughter she will stand up there as long as he likes, because she has heard the answers and none of them is going to get her.

The other thing I must put down is the monk. He came in March on the Greyhound with one bag. He is thirty-three. There is no pagoda on this Coast. He rented the Fayard house next to mine, the little shotgun, and I think he rented it for the yard, since there is nothing to the house. Seven mimosa trees stand along my fence on his side. They are in flower now, and they drop pink threads on my wash. He hung the flag with the six colors on his porch post, and he sits under the trees. Everybody calls him thầy, teacher, which is what a monk is called, by ours and theirs both. People say he worked his uncle’s deck at Port Arthur before he took the robe, and he does look at a boat the way a deckhand looks at one. I take him rice over the fence on Fridays, since I am cooking without meat anyway.

This morning at the fence he asked me which evenings they sing at the fuel dock. I told him. He said, *Today, then,* and went and sat down under the end tree.

II. Seven Mimosas

Next door · a little after four · saw

I WAS TAKING IN THE WASH WHEN ÚT CAME UP THE STREET IN a clean shirt. He decks on the *Sao Mai*. He is twenty-two and his mother's last, and he has been making up his answer since Tết. Half the Point has heard pieces of it.

The thầy did not get up. *Út.*

Dạ, thầy.

Come here.

He came in at the gate and bowed and sat down on his heels on the pink.

Where are you going?

To the fuel dock, thầy. Where ông Bảy's daughter sings.

Do you have an answer for her?

I have one.

Say it.

Út sang it. He has a voice. It was all a captain with his six doors on the bottom and his nets full and no bank over him. I thought it as good as any I have written down.

That is no answer, the thầy said. *You have the number right and the wrong doors. I will give you one. Will you carry it down there?*

I will, thầy.

How many doors does ông Bảy put in the water?

Six. Two to a net, and the two little ones on the try net.

Those are his. Count your own. And he touched his eye, and his ear, and the side of his nose. He put out the tip of his tongue like a boy. He laid one hand flat on the back of the other, and last he set a finger to his forehead. *Things come in at these all day and all night. The man who is master of*

all six is a king, and you have not met him. The man who hangs up on what comes in, the mud has him. Now say this after me.

> Six doors he has, and none of wood.
> Who rules all six, that one is king.
> The king who clings, the mud is his master.
> Who does not cling comes up clear.
> The one who clings they call the fool.

When you have sung that, she will sing you a second verse. Nobody has heard it yet. It asks what carries the fool away, and how the wise man holds against it, and how a man gets loose from the yoke. Then you sing this.

> The flood tide carries the fool away.
> By his own work the wise man holds.
> Unyoked from every yoke there is,
> that man is called let go.

Út said them over. The thầy kept him at it until there was none of the boy's own tune left in them. I had the last sheet over my arm and I did not go in. Somewhere in the saying, something went out of that boy's face. He had come up Oak Street like one going to win a girl and a boat. He went back down it like a man carrying a full pot in both hands.

III. Channel Sixty-Eight

The base radio · a little before six to twenty past seven · heard

The fuel dock is four blocks from this kitchen, and I have never once gone down to it on a singing night. I have no need. The *Sao Mai* ties up nearest, and her captain hangs his mike out the wheelhouse window, and somebody always puts it over on the sideband for the boats outside.

5:55 THANH TÂM, sideband. Ship Shoal. Forty boxes. Weather fair. He asks is the old man standing his girl up tonight. I say it is the fifteenth, what does he think. He says leave the sideband on.

6:20 SAO MAI. Ông Bảy is coming round. People on the bulkhead from the ice house to the net shop, sitting with their legs over. Cars from Louisiana.

6:31 STELLA MARIS, old Captain Tony, in English. *Mr. Bay has got his hook down right in the channel again. Somebody tell him I draw six feet.*

6:33 SAO MAI. She is on the roof.

6:35 The mike goes out the window. I hear water on the pilings, and then I hear her. *Hò ơ.*

> Which captain is the one that is king?
> Which king has got the mud for master?
> How does he come clear of the mud?
> And which one do they call the fool?

6:38 A boy from Bayou La Batre, off the HÀI ÂU. The captain with a steel hull is king, he sings, and the worms are master of the wooden one. SAO MAI: *She says no.*

6:44 A boy from Versailles, in New Orleans East. The king is the man who owes no bank. Laughing all down the bulkhead. *She says no.*

6:51 Two brothers from Port Arthur, singing together. The king is the price the dealer chalks on the board, and every captain is ruled by it. That one gets a cheer. *She says no. The old man has not looked out of the wheelhouse.*

6:58 STELLA MARIS. *How long does this go on?*

6:59 SAO MAI, in English. *Four years, Captain.*

7:02 SAO MAI. Út is here. He is coming down the bulkhead through them. They are sitting so thick that he is knocking knees. He says, *Let me by. I have brought an answer.*

7:04 I hear him. He does not sing what he sang for himself in the yard at four o'clock. He sings what he was given, all five lines, as I have them above. *Six doors he has, and none of wood.*

7:05 Nothing on the channel. Water on the pilings.

7:06 She is singing again, and it is not the first verse. In four years I have never written down a second verse.

> What is it carries the fool away?
> How does the wise man hold against it?
> How does a man get loose from the yoke?
> Tell me that, if you are able.

7:07 Út. *The flood tide carries the fool away.* All four lines.

7:08 SAO MAI. The old man is out of the wheelhouse. He is on the deck. He is saying something. He says, *A thầy has come. There is a thầy in this country.* He has gone back in.

7:08 Horn. I hear it out of the radio and I hear it through my window.

7:09 STELLA MARIS. *He has got her wide open. Bay! You are on your anchor!*

7:09 SAO MAI. He has put the wheel over. She is going round her anchor like a dog on a chain.

7:10 STELLA MARIS. *There go the skiffs. He has put water over the bulkhead on both sides. It is up to the ice house door. There are men in the bay. I count fifteen. Twenty.*

7:10 Channel sixteen. Somebody calls men in the water at the Back Bay fuel dock. COAST GUARD GULFPORT answers and asks how many persons.

7:11 SAO MAI. He has stopped her. He is letting his booms down. Both nets are going in the water, doors and all.

7:12 STELLA MARIS. *I am looking at it. They are climbing into his webbing. He is taking them up on the winch. He is landing those men on the dock like a tow of shrimp. I have fished here fifty-one years.*

7:13 Channel sixteen. STELLA MARIS to the Coast Guard. *Disregard. All persons are on the dock. They are laughing.*

7:15 LÁ DỪA NƯỚC. In four years I have not written that name in the left column. He does not talk on the radio. *Út. Where is the thầy?*

7:15 Út, on the SAO MAI's mike. *Under the mimosas, ông. Next to Cô Năm's.*

7:16 LÁ DỪA NƯỚC. *Come. We are going.*

7:20 SAO MAI. Everyone is going. The whole bulkhead is getting up.

I put the pencil down and turned off the stove.

IV. One Leaf

Next door · ten to eight · saw, and heard twice

They came up Oak Street in the last of the light, with the moon rising behind them over the Point. I would say two hundred. Út was in front, and ông Bảy behind him in his white boots, and the girl. After them came the ones he had fished out, still dripping, and then the rest, ours and theirs, Buddhist and Catholic, and some of the old families' men who had only followed the crowd. They filled the street as far as my gate.

A deckhand off the *Kim Hoa* had a hand radio on his belt. When the old man went in at the thầy's gate, that boy held the key down and kept it down. So everything that follows I heard two times, once through the window screen and once out of the radio on my counter. I wrote from whichever was clearer.

Ông Bảy went in under the flag and under the trees. The thầy was sitting where he had sat since morning. The old man got down on the pink threads in his boots and put his forehead to the ground three times. Then he stood off to one side with his hands hanging, and he cried. He is sixty-two. I have known him eight years and I had not known he could.

What is this, bác? the thầy said.

He called himself *con*, child, as a person does before the robe, though this monk was young enough to be his son.

Thầy. Con was a monk. Con took the ten at twelve years old, in a temple on a canal below Sa Đéc, and the full precepts at twenty.

The spring after that, three of us went down the canal in the temple's boat to chant for a dead man. The tide was going out and the boat ran with it. The wa-

ter coconut is thick there on both banks, and the fronds hang out over the water. Con put out a hand and took hold of a leaf. Why, con cannot tell you. A young man puts out his hand. The boat went on, and con did not open the hand, and the leaf tore away. One blade of it, as long as this arm.

A monk does not break a growing thing. It is a small rule. You say it to another monk before the recitation, on a day like this one, and it is finished. Con looked at it and thought, it is a leaf. Con dropped it in the canal and did not say it. Not that fortnight, and not the next. After a year, how do you say it? After ten? Con kept every other rule there is for thirty-two rains, and that leaf lay unsaid under all of them.

In '78 the district took the temple for a rice store and told the monks to go home and produce. Con had no home. In '79 con went out from Rạch Giá in a river boat with a hundred and ten people. The engine stopped on the second day. On the fifth day there was no water. On the sixth con lay in the bottom of the boat and felt a thing laid across here.

He put the edge of his hand against his throat.

Thin and cool, with an edge to it. Con knew what it was. Con looked down the boat for a monk to say it to. A hundred and ten people, and not one shaved head. Con said out loud, My precepts are broken. The ones lying nearest thought it was a man asking for water.

That is where the monk died, thầy. What went up the side of the tanker the next morning was some other kind of thing, with somebody's child holding on to its shirt. They sent it to Mississippi. They stood it at a table on the Back Bay at five in the morning and put an oyster knife in its hand. Thirty-two rains, and con comes up in a town where everything that breathes lives by killing what is small in the water. Then the shrimp. Con is good at it. They call con a king. Con kills more in one tow than there are people in this town.

Eight years. In eight years con has not had a man's life, or heard one line of the Dharma, or laid eyes on a monk. Con named the boat for it, so as to have to read it every time con came down the dock. Con gave the girl the song because con thought, if a true teacher ever comes to this country, some boy he has taught will carry the answer down to the water, and con will know.

All of it for a leaf, thầy. One leaf.

V. The Door in the Net

The same yard · heard twice

For a while there was only the key held down, and the street breathing.

Bác, the thầy said. *You are saying it to a monk now. Do you see it?*

Con sees it.

Then be careful after this.

That was all he did about the leaf. I am Catholic and I waited for more, and there was no more. Then he spoke to the old man, but loud enough for the street.

It is hard to come by a human life. You came to this one in a river boat, bác. You know how hard. It is hard to keep one. It is hard to hear the Dharma even once. And harder than all of these is for a Buddha to come into the world. That takes work and trouble past any counting.

They say the government is going to make every one of you cut a door in his nets this year, to let the turtle out. You know how big the Gulf is. You know how big that door will be. The sutra says it is like that. One turtle, one hole, and the whole sea. That is how often a person is born where the Dharma can be heard. And every one of you standing in this street has put his neck through.

Then he said it as it stands in their book, where two sons say it to their father and mother. He was a young man saying it to an old one, and he did not change the words.

> *It is most difficult to meet with this superior law, even in myriads of kotis of Æons; very rare are the beings who will adhere to the superior law which they have heard from me.*
>
> *— Saddharma-Pundarika II.135*
>
> *For, father and mother, the appearance of a Buddha is rare to be met with as the blossom of the glomerated fig-tree, as the entering of the tortoise's neck into the hole of the yoke formed by the great ocean. The appearance of Lords Buddhas, father and mother, is rare. Hence, father and mother, it is a happy lot we have been blessed with, to have been born at the time of such a prophet.*
>
> *— Saddharma-Pundarika XXV*

He stopped. The boy from the *Kim Hoa* let go of the key. The radio on my counter gave the small hiss it gives when a channel comes empty, and then nothing, the way it is at three in the morning.

Then somebody clicked his mike twice. That is how a captain says *I heard you* when he has nothing to add. Another did it. Then they came in one on top of another, loud ones from the harbor first, and after those the thin ones from outside, boats I could not have named. On the sideband it was the same from the Louisiana side, and my husband says from Texas. I made a mark in the book for each until I had eighty-four marks and the line was full. They did not stop when I did.

How many in the street understood him I cannot write, because that does not come over a radio. Some of them sat down in his yard that night, and some of those were ours.

VI. After Dark

Oak Street · saw

The girl had a jade bangle on her wrist. It was her dead mother's, and it came through two sets of pirates sewn in a hem. She worked it off over her hand and set it down in front of the thầy, and he took it up at once, in both hands. I do not know what that means with

THEM. MY DAUGHTER SAYS NGỌC UNDERSTOOD HIM BEFORE the old man had finished crying.

Út did not ask for the girl or the boat. He said he had only carried it. She said that was the first right thing any of them had said in four years. They were married in the eleventh month. That is not in this book, but I was there.

Ông Bảy would have asked for the robe again that same evening. But he is sixty-two, and three families eat off his nets, and a bank in Gulfport holds the paper on the *Lá Dừa*. The thầy did not tell him yes and did not tell him no. He said the trees would be there on the first and the fifteenth. The old man says now that there are five times when he can be nothing but a shrimper: the morning the season opens; when the nets come up; when he is asleep in the bunk behind the wheel; when he sits with the other captains at the fuel dock; and when he dies, which he expects to do with ice in his cuffs. The rest of the time he is in that yard.

9:40 THANH TÂM, sideband. He asks did I write it. I say every word. He says, *Read it to me.* I read him what the thầy said, from the hard life to the turtle, and the part out of their book as near as I got it. When I finish there are clicks again, from boats I do not know.

10:15 Nothing on sixty-eight.

When I went to shut the kitchen window the old man was still out there, standing under the end tree by himself. A branch hung down beside his shoulder. Those trees close their leaves at night, every small pair folding flat together with nobody touching them, and it was doing that. He had his hands behind his back.

Background

The verse

> *Difficult (to obtain) is the conception of men, difficult is the life of mortals, difficult is the hearing of the True Law, difficult is the birth of the Awakened (the attainment of Buddhahood).*
>
> Dhammapada 182, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young monk in the time of an earlier Buddha, riding in a boat down the Ganges, catches hold of a leaf of an eraka plant and does not let go, and it tears off. Damaging a plant is a small breach of the monks' rule, cleared by admitting it to another monk. He thinks it a trifle and never does. After twenty thousand years of faultless practice he lies dying, feels the leaf at his throat, finds no monk to confess to, and is reborn as Erakapatta ("Eraka-leaf"), a serpent king the size of a dugout. To learn whether a Buddha has arisen, he sets his daughter in his raised hood on the river every fortnight to sing a riddle, with herself and his wealth as the prize. For a whole age no one answers. The Buddha, seated under seven trees, teaches a young man named Uttara the answer (the king is the one who rules the six doors of the senses). When the serpent hears it he lashes the river in joy, floods both banks, lifts the swamped men out in his hood, and goes weeping to the Buddha, who gives him the verse. Eighty-four thousand listeners understand; the serpent, being an animal, cannot. Read the full commentary story, or about nāgas. The riddle and its answers in the story are rendered from the commentary's own verses. The sutra the monk recites is the Lotus Sutra, in Hendrik Kern's translation of 1884; the same sutra tells of a serpent king's young daughter who hands the Buddha a jewel and is awakened on the spot.

Biloxi, Mississippi

Biloxi, 1987

Refugees from Vietnam began settling on the Mississippi coast in the late 1970s, many of them fishing families who had escaped by sea as boat people. They started in Biloxi's oyster and shrimp houses, bought and built boats, and through the 1980s became a growing share of the fleet working out of the Back Bay and Point Cadet, alongside the older Croatian ("Slavonian") and French fishing families whose Blessing of the Fleet, with its Shrimp King and Queen, dates from 1929. Many of the newcomers were Catholic; the Buddhists among them had no temple until a pagoda opened in a house on East Howard Avenue in December 1988. See Vietnamese in Mississippi. Cô Năm, her log, the monk and the boats are invented. The full moon of the fourth lunar month, kept as the Buddha's birthday, fell on May 12 in 1987.

A Gulf shrimp trawler of the time towed a net from each outrigger, each net held open by a pair of wooden doors, and sampled the bottom with a small try net that had two doors of its own: six in the water. A "hang" is a snag that catches a net. In 1987 federal rules were on the way requiring a turtle excluder device in shrimp nets, an escape opening for sea turtles that Gulf shrimpers fought for years. The palm is the nipa, *Nypa fruticans*, in Vietnamese *dừa nước*, "water coconut." The commentary's seven trees are *sirīsa*, an Albizia; the mimosa of Southern yards is its cousin *Albizia julibrissin*, whose leaves fold shut at night.

After the story of the nāga king Erakapatta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 182). The original. Scripture from the Saddharma-Pundarika, or Lotus of the True Law, translated by H. Kern (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 21, 1884). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

14.4

The Souvenir Journal

First, By doing no harm, by avoiding evil of every kind, especially that which is most generally practised
— The General Rules, A.M.E. Discipline (1817)

The way I received it, on Old Halls Ferry Road.

I. Our Shepherds

Coppin Chapel A.M.E. Church, Black Jack, Missouri · September 2004

Sister Nanette Givens had been clerk of Coppin Chapel for nineteen years, and the church said of her that if the roll book ever burned she could write it out again from the front pew back, with the birthdays. She had retired from Southwestern Bell in 1996 after thirty-one years of other people's telephone numbers, and she still had most of them. Now the Fortieth Anniversary was five Sundays off, and the Souvenir Journal was hers.

On a Thursday afternoon she sat in the church office with the proofs. Out the window was the parking lot, where under the yellow lines the trustees had painted you could still make out the white ones the Lutherans had left, slanting the other way. The Lutherans had built the place in 1961, when the subdivisions were going in for the McDonnell men, and sold it in 1979, when Coppin Chapel came out to the County behind its own members. Across Old Halls Ferry Road was a strip of stores: a beauty supply, a Chinese carry-out, and a place that did taxes in the spring and sat dark the rest of the year.

The ads were in. There was the full page from the funeral home, as there was in every journal of every church north of the highway. There were half pages from the barber college and the State Farm man, and two

pages of patrons at ten dollars a name. The history was in, beginning in a storefront on Easton Avenue in 1964, the Easton Avenue that is Dr. Martin Luther King Drive now. What she had in front of her was the center spread, which she had headed OUR SHEPHERDS. It ran to seven columns. Six of them had a black rule around the photograph. In the seventh was Pastor Meeks in her robe.

She had done it right. For every one of the seven she had set down who the mother and father were and what town they came from. She had the years at Coppin Chapel, and where each one got the call and under whose preaching. She had how many were on the roll in that pastor's time. She had the two who stood closest, the steward pro tem and the head of the trustees. And she had the one member who had stood behind the pastor with money when money was the question, which in Reverend Tate's column was Mother Ida Crump, who signed her own house over against the note on this building. All of it came out of the conference minutes and the old bulletins and her own head, and all of it was checked.

Reading down the columns, she saw what was not there.

The General Rules were printed in the front of the Discipline, as they had been since Richard Allen's people first printed one, and the oldest Discipline told the elder in charge to read them out to the people. In the organizing minutes for 1964 she had found a line in a hand like copperplate: *Rev. Broadnax read the General Rules entire.* After that there was nothing for seven years. She could remember hearing them herself at Watch Night under Reverend Pettis, with the lights down. She heard them now on the first Sunday of every quarter. But she could not have said how the six before had kept them, whether the same as now or some other way. It was not in the minutes, and a thing that was not written down sat badly with her.

She squared the proofs and went down the hall to the pastor's study.

II. The Study

The same afternoon

Reverend Yolanda Meeks was fifty-one. She had dispatched buses for Bi-State for twenty-two years before she answered her call, and she still said a thing one time and expected it to get where it was going. The Bishop had read her name out to Coppin Chapel two conferences ago. On the shelf behind her desk, between the hymnal and the current Discipline, stood a thin brown book that had been Reverend Broadnax's, a reprint of the first Discipline of 1817. He had penciled dates in its margin.

Pastor, Sister Nan said, *the six before you. Did they keep the Rules the way we keep them? Or did each one have a different way?*

Pastor Meeks did not reach for the book.

The time was different with every one. Reverend Broadnax read the Rules to this church once in seven years. Three times in his whole pastorate. Mother Crump will tell you they lived on one reading until the next. Reverend Tate read them once in his six years, the Sunday we came into this building, and Dr. Lyles once in his six. Reverend Pettis and Reverend Coates read them every year, him at Watch Night and her on Founder's Day. Reverend Sample read them every six months. She turned her pen end for end on the blotter. *I read them every quarter, the way that first book says to. And I could not swear to you that mine last out the month.*

Then which of you had it right?

That is the time, Sister Nan. You asked me about the time. The words were never different. Any one of the seven of us stood up and opened to the same page.

She knew the page, and she said the three heads of it across the desk.

> *First, By doing no harm, by avoiding evil of every kind, especially that which is most generally practised:*
>
> *Secondly, By doing good, by being in every kind, merciful according to their power;*
>
> *Thirdly, By attending upon all the ordinances of God:*
>
> *— The General Rules of the United Societies*

If you want a line to go under every name, put that. It is the same under every name.

III. Anniversary Sunday

The third Sunday in October

Pastor Meeks came down out of the pulpit to read them. She stood on the floor in front of the rail in her robe, with Reverend Broadnax's brown book open on her hand, and she read them entire, and slowly. In the choir stand the children had been told to sit still and were doing what they could.

Sister Nan had the clerk's seat, second pew on the aisle, and she turned in it far enough to watch the right side of the church. Eleven were left who had been on Easton Avenue. They sat together, as they always had. Mother Ida Crump was ninety-three and had not known her own granddaughter since Easter. She sat in her white with both hands on the bar of her walker, looking at the floor. When the pastor came to the list under the first head, Mother Crump's lips began to move, and by the third line she was half a beat in front.

> *Fighting, quarrelling, brawling, brother going to law with brother; returning evil for evil; or railing for railing;*
>
> *Uncharitable or unprofitable conversation: particularly speaking evil of magistrates or of ministers.*
>
> *Softness, and needless self-indulgence.*
>
> *— The General Rules, under the first head*

At *or of ministers* somebody in the back said *Well,* and the church laughed, and Pastor Meeks let them. Brother Teasdale had his eyes shut and was saying it too, and both the Hinton sisters, and the rest of the eleven. Not one of them had a book. It went on that way through the second head and the third, the one voice from the floor and the old ones under it, dry as leaves.

> *By running with patience the race which is set before them, denying themselves, and taking up their cross daily;*
>
> *Family and private prayer: Searching the scriptures, and Fasting or abstinence.*
>
> *— The General Rules, under the second and third heads*

Sister Nan did the sum because she could not help doing sums. Reverend Broadnax had read these words to those eleven people three times, in 1964 and 1971 and 1978. The last of the three was twenty-six years gone.

There was dinner afterward in the fellowship hall, with the ruby tablecloths the anniversary committee had rented. Out on the lot a girl from the children's choir had a clapping game going with two others. *First, do no harm. Second, do good.* They could not get the third head to fit the claps, and kept starting over.

Sister Nan drove Mother Crump home, as she did every Sunday, down Old Halls Ferry and in among the courts. Mother Crump had a plate on her knees under foil. Twice she asked whose car this was, and twice Sister Nan told her. They passed a man washing a truck in his driveway, and a yard where somebody had the ball game on a radio. Mother Crump looked out at all of it and said, quite clearly, to nobody:

> *To their bodies of the ability which God giveth, by giving food to the hungry, by clothing the naked, by visiting or helping them that are sick, or in prison.*
>
> *— The General Rules, under the second head*

Mother, who is the plate for?

Mother Crump looked down at the foil as if somebody had set it on her while she slept. She had made up a plate for somebody sick after every church dinner for forty years. She had made up this one, and she did not know.

Sister Nan knew the sick list the way she knew the roll. She put on her signal and turned away from the daughter's court, toward the Florissant side, where Brother Hampton had been laid up since his stroke.

Background

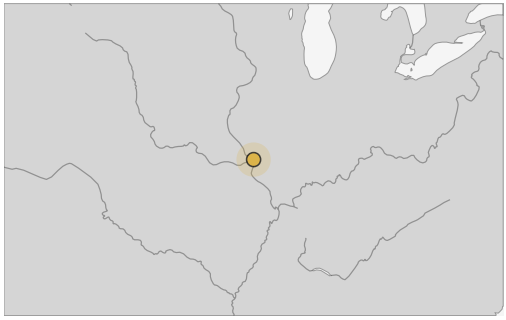
The verses

> *Not to commit any sin, to do good, and to purify one's mind, that is the teaching of (all) the Awakened.*
>
> Dhammapada 183, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The Awakened call patience the highest penance, long-suffering the highest Nirvana; for he is not an anchorite (pravragita) who strikes others, he is not an ascetic (sramana) who insults others.*
>
> Dhammapada 184, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Not to blame, not to strike, to live restrained under the law, to be moderate in eating, to sleep and sit alone, and to dwell on the highest thoughts,--this is the teaching of the Awakened.*
>
> Dhammapada 185, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the elder Ānanda, sitting alone, reflects that the Buddha has described the six Buddhas before him in every particular (their parents, their length of life, the tree each awakened under, their following, their two chief disciples, their chief supporter) but has never said how they kept the Observance Day, the regular gathering at which the community's rule is recited. He asks whether it was the same as now. The Buddha answers that the interval differed, once in seven years for Vipassī, six for the next two, yearly for the two after, every six months for Kassapa, and that one day's admonition lasted the whole interval; but the words were the same for all of them, and he recites the three verses. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda, the Buddhas before Gotama and the Observance Day.



Black Jack, Missouri

North St. Louis County, 2004

The General Rules were written by John Wesley in 1743 for the first Methodist societies, under three heads: doing no harm, doing good, and attending upon the ordinances of God. American Methodists printed them at the front of their book of Discipline, and when Richard Allen and his colleagues organized the African Methodist Episcopal Church in Philadelphia in 1816, their first *Doctrines and Discipline* (1817) carried the Rules too, with a direction that the elder in charge read them "once a year in every congregation, and once a quarter in every society." The wording quoted in the story is that of 1817. A.M.E. pastors are appointed by the bishop at each annual conference and moved from charge to charge, which is how a church of forty years comes to have had seven. The anniversary souvenir journal, with its history, its page of pastors and its paid advertisements, is a fixture of Black church life. Coppin Chapel and its people are invented.

Black Jack lies in the northern suburbs of St. Louis, among subdivisions built in the 1950s and 1960s, when the McDonnell aircraft plants nearby were hiring. Residents incorporated it as a city in 1970 and at once zoned out an interfaith group's apartment project meant for families from the city; a federal appeals court struck the ordinance down in 1974. Black families moved into North County through the 1970s and after, many congregations followed their members out from the city, and by the 2000 census Black Jack was about seventy-one percent African American. Easton Avenue in St. Louis was renamed for Dr. Martin Luther King in 1972.

After the story of Ānanda's question about the Observance Day from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 183–185). The original. Scripture from John Wesley's General Rules of the United Societies (1743), as printed in the Doctrines and Discipline of the African Methodist Episcopal Church (1817). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

14.5

A Hundred Eggs

> *He that loveth silver shall not be satisfied with silver.*
> *— Ecclesiastes 5:9*

Azoy dertseylt men, on the county line road.

I. Yoreh De'ah

Williamsburg and Farmingdale · February 1963

Leib Feder had been learning in the kollel at Lakewood for three years when the mashgiach called him in after Maariv and told him to go to Brooklyn for the winter. There was a rav in Williamsburg, an old man from Hungary, who taught the laws a rabbi needs, the laws of what is kosher and what is not, salting and soaking and the lung of an ox, and he took two or three young men a season into his apartment over a fish store on Lee Avenue and drilled them until they could answer a question about a chicken in their sleep. *Go,* said the mashgiach. *Learn it properly. Come back in Nisan with semicha.*

The Rosh Yeshiva had died in November. Twenty-five thousand people had stood in the streets of the Lower East Side for the funeral, and the yeshiva he had brought to the pine woods twenty years before with fifteen students had two hundred and fifty, and nobody yet knew what it would be without him. It seemed a good winter to be sent somewhere and told exactly what to do.

So Leib slept on a cot in the rav's front room under a window that smelled of carp, and learned the laws of the lung, and did not go home on Shabbos because the rav did not hold with young men running back and forth. Raizel stayed in Lakewood with the baby and taught first grade. Nobody had a telephone. His mother wrote on Sundays.

His father had a chicken farm in Farmingdale, five thousand White Leghorns in a long two-story coop of five hundred birds to a room, which he had bought in 1948 with a mortgage from the Jewish Agricultural Society and his whole savings from twenty years of pressing pants on Pitkin Avenue. After the war eggs had brought ninety cents a dozen. That winter they brought twenty-five. Moshe Feder carried the hundred-pound sacks of Purina up the coop stairs himself, two at a time, because he would not pay a man to do what he could do, and in the second week of February he sat down at the top of the stairs with a sack on his shoulder and did not get up.

He lived four days in the hospital in Neptune. He asked for Leib. He asked for him so often that the nurses learned the name. Mendy, who was fifteen, rode the bus to Lakewood to find him and found that he was in Brooklyn, and nobody at the yeshiva could say exactly where, and a letter was sent and went to the wrong fish store. On the fourth day the old man talked to Leib for an hour as though he were sitting beside the bed, about the farm and the price of feed and a boy who had once learned the whole of a tractate by heart before he was bar mitzvah. Then he took an envelope out from under his pillow and put it in Mendy's hand and closed Mendy's fingers on it.

For Leibel, he said. *A Shas and a tallis. The best. Not from the cheap shelf.*

He died that night.

The letter found Leib the morning of the funeral, and he came down on the bus in time to stand at the grave with his coat torn. At the shiva in the farmhouse kitchen, with the mirrors covered and the coop still clattering across the yard because the hens did not know, Mendy came in from feeding them with feathers on his sleeves and threw himself down on the linoleum at Leib's feet, on the low stool, and cried with his face against his brother's shoes.

He talked about you the whole time. The whole time, Leib. He gave me this.

On the envelope, in their father's Yiddish, was written *far Leybl, a shas un a tales*. Inside there were eighteen hundred-dollar bills, a hundred times chai, folded once.

Leib pushed it back into his brother's hand. *I don't need this. Give it to Mama.*

His mother would not take it. It sat on the kitchen windowsill all week, under a jar of pennies, while people came in out of the cold to sit with them.

II. Eighteen Hundred Dollars

Lakewood · March and April 1963

He did not go back to Williamsburg. The rav sent word that he understood. Leib went back to Lakewood and to the kollel, and to the minyan three times a day to say Kaddish, and for a few weeks he learned as he always had.

Then he began to do arithmetic.

The farm would have to be sold. His mother could not run it and Mendy was a boy. The agent from the Society had come and walked through the coop with his hands behind his back and said what it would bring, and it was half of what Moshe Feder had paid. All up and down the county the farms were going that way, Toms River and Jackson and Howell, men who had come out of the camps or out of the sweatshops to have a piece of ground and something alive to tend, selling out for what they could get to men who built houses. In Lakewood the great hotels in the pines stood half empty in the winter season, and at the edge of town a sign had gone up for a village for retired people.

And Leib thought: I could keep it.

He thought it first at night. Then he thought it in the beis medrash, over the open Gemara, with his chavrusa reading aloud across the table. What was he doing here? He was twenty-four years old with a wife and a child. He lived on what the kollel gave, and the kollel lived on what the meshulachim brought back from knocking on doors in Brooklyn and Cleveland and Toronto, hat in hand, with a receipt book. Every slice of bread he ate, some Jew in Flatbush had been asked for at his own front door. What kind of life was that for a man? Whereas eighteen hundred

dollars. With eighteen hundred dollars a man could keep a farm going a season. A man could stand on his own feet.

He stopped learning. He sat in his place with the Gemara open and turned the pages at about the right speed. He stopped going to the night seder. He said Kaddish in a voice like a man reading a list. He did not sleep, and he did not eat much, and by Pesach his face had gone a color that made Raizel put her hand on his forehead.

It was the younger boys who said something first, the unmarried ones at the long tables in the back of the beis medrash, who noticed everything.

Reb Leib, what's the matter? You look like a lemon.

I'm not happy, Leib said. *That's all.*

They went and told the mashgiach, and the mashgiach called in Leib's chavrusa, Avrohom Wolpe, and the two of them talked for a long time. Then the mashgiach put on his hat.

You want to be a chicken farmer, he said to Leib. *So we will go and ask a chicken farmer.*

III. The Grading Room

The county line road, Jackson Township · May 1963

Reb Zalman Mintz had three thousand Leghorns on twelve acres of sand at the edge of the pines, where the county line road ran toward Freewood Acres, and he brought eggs to the yeshiva kitchen every Thursday in a green panel truck. That was all most of the boys knew about him. A few knew more. Before the war, it was said, he had been one of the best heads in the yeshiva at Kletzk. He had come to this country in 1949 with nobody, from where nobody asked, and bought the farm with a loan from the Society, and lived on it alone. He would not give a shiur. He would not take an honor in shul. But he learned every night in the beis medrash from ten until two, at a table by the radiator, and more than once Leib had seen the mashgiach himself go over to that table with a sefer under his arm and stand there like a boy waiting to be called on.

They found him in the basement of the farmhouse, in the grading room. It was cool and dim and smelled of lime and straw. He was sitting on a stool in front of a wooden box with a light bulb inside it and a round hole cut in the front, taking eggs one at a time out of a wire basket and holding each one up to the hole so the light came through it. The shell went the color of a lampshade, and inside it you could see the shadow of the yolk swinging, and the air cell at the blunt end, and whether there was a crack or a spot of blood. The clean ones he set in the flat on his left. The others he set aside.

He did not stop when they came in. The mashgiach explained. Reb Zalman listened with an egg held up to the light.

Is it true? he said to Leib. *You're not happy?*

It's true.

Why? You have something to live on?

Yes.

How much?

Eighteen hundred dollars.

Reb Zalman set the egg in the flat. *Good. Bring me a hundred eggs.*

There was a case of ungraded eggs by the stairs, thirty dozen in pressed paper trays. Leib carried out one tray after another and counted eggs onto the long grading table, carefully, because they rolled, until there were a hundred of them lying on the boards in the light of the bulb.

Each one is eighteen dollars, said Reb Zalman. *Now. Put fifty there.* He pointed with his chin. *That is a year of bread. You, your wife, the little one. Rent, shoes, the doctor. Light. That is not a lot, for a year.*

Leib moved fifty eggs to the end of the table.

Twenty-four for pullets. You will need new birds; your father's are old, they are laying small. Twenty-four for feed. A hen eats. When goods increase, they are increased that eat them. Twenty-four for the roof of the coop, which I have seen and which leaks.

Leib moved twenty-four eggs, and then twenty-four more. There were two eggs left on the boards in front of him.

Twenty-four for a truck, because your father's truck is older than you are. Twenty-four for the scraper and the lime and the man to help you with the ma-

nure, because you have never done it, and I have, and I am telling you that you cannot do it alone. He looked at the two eggs. *Nu?*

Leib said nothing. He was looking at the two eggs.

And this is if eggs stay at twenty-five cents, said Reb Zalman. *Which they will not. They will go down.*

He took another egg out of the wire basket and held it up to the light and looked at it.

So little, and with this you want to fill yourself up?

IV. The King

The grading room, the same afternoon

THE MASHGIACH HAD SAT DOWN ON AN UPTURNED FEED BUCKet. Avrohom Wolpe stood by the stairs. Nobody said anything, and after a while Reb Zalman began to talk, still candling, an egg in his fingers the whole time, and set each one down where it belonged as he went.

There was a king, he said. *A long time ago. He had everything a king has, and seven treasures besides, and when he shut his left hand and struck it with his right, it rained. Not water. Gold. Pearls, stones, every kind, up to the knee, like hail, over the whole country. He was a prince for a long time, and he helped his father rule for a long time, and he was king for a long time. Longer than any of us.*

One day he was sad. His ministers said, Majesty, what is it? He said, Look what I can do. What is this little kingdom, to a man who can do what I can do? Where is there better? They said, Majesty, there is only up.

So he went up. To the first heaven, where there are four kings, one at each corner of the world. They came out to meet him with flowers and gave him their throne, and he sat there. A long time. And then he began to get yellow in the face, like our friend here. The four kings said, Majesty, what is it? He said, What is better than this? They said, We are only servants. Above us there is another heaven, and the King of that heaven.

So he went up again. And the King of that heaven came out to meet him with flowers, and took him in, and gave him half of his own chair. They ruled together. His eldest son, meanwhile, took the golden wheel that went before him every-

where, and went home with it, down to the earth, and was king there. The father did not even notice.

Reb Zalman set down an egg with a spot in it, apart from the others.

The King of that heaven lives a very long time. Longer than the world has been. Then he dies, and another one comes, and this one also gave our king half the chair. Then another. Thirty-six of them, one after the other. Thirty-six. He paused, and the mashgiach looked at the floor, and Leib understood that the number was not an accident. *And still the king sat on half a chair.*

And one day he thought: Why half? I will kill this one and sit on the whole of it. He could not. You cannot kill such a one. But from wanting it, he got old. In heaven nobody gets old. So he fell. He fell all the way down, out of the sky, into a garden. A garden like the Goulds' on the lake in Lakewood, with the stone pools. The gardener found him lying on the grass and ran to the palace, and the royal family came and made him a bed under the trees.

They said to him, Majesty, what shall we tell the people? He said: Tell them that the king of kings, who ruled the four corners of the earth and all the islands of the sea, who ruled over the four kings of the first heaven, who sat on the chair of heaven while thirty-six Kings of heaven lived and died, is dead. And he died.

He put the egg in his hand into the flat. The flat was full. He slid it onto the stack and pulled an empty one toward him.

It rained gold to his knees, he said, *and he died hungry.*

Then, without looking up, he said it the way you say a thing you have said to yourself many times, at a table by a radiator at two in the morning.

> *He that loveth silver shall not be satisfied with silver; nor he that loveth abundance, with increase; this also is vanity.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 5:9*

Leib looked at the hundred eggs, the long row and the shorter rows and the two by themselves. He thought about his father at the top of the coop stairs with a sack on his shoulder. He thought about the farms on Route 9 going one by one to men who built houses, and about every one of those men, who had all wanted a piece of ground and had got it and then wanted the next ten acres and the bigger coop and the second truck. He

thought about the eggs going down to twenty cents and to fifteen, and how many more eggs it would take then to make the same eighteen hundred dollars, and how a man would lie awake doing that sum.

And the other thing, said Reb Zalman. *The thing you are sitting with in the beis medrash with a face like a lemon.* He turned the egg in his fingers against the light. *That one does not need eighteen hundred dollars. It does not need a farm. It does not even need heaven, with all the chairs.*

> *Whom have I in heaven but Thee? And beside Thee I desire none upon earth.*
>
> *— Psalm 73:25*

He held out the egg to Leib. Leib took it and held it up to the hole in the box, as he had seen done, and looked. It was clear all the way through, the yolk a soft round shadow, nothing wrong in it anywhere, and the light coming through the shell made his fingers glow red at the edges.

Clean, said Leib.

So put it with the clean ones, said Reb Zalman, and went on with his work.

V. The Sand Road

Toward Freewood Acres · evening

The mashgiach rode back to Lakewood with Avrohom Wolpe in the yeshiva's car. Leib said he would walk. It was eight miles and nobody argued with him.

He went north first, the wrong way, up the sand road past the last of the coops, without any reason except that he did not want to arrive yet. The pines were full of the smell of the day's heat going out of them. At a farmhouse with a tin-roofed porch, where the road bent toward Freewood Acres and the Kalmyk people lived, a man was standing at the door.

He was a monk, Leib supposed, though he had never seen one. He was bald, in a plain cotton robe the color of dried blood, and he was holding out a wooden bowl in both hands. A woman in an apron came to the

screen door with a kettle and filled the bowl with something milky and steaming, and the monk lifted it in both hands and drank it standing on the step, all of it, slowly, as though there were nothing else he needed to be doing that evening or any evening. There was a brass staple across a split in the rim of the bowl. Leib could see it shine when he tipped it up. Then the monk bowed to the woman, and she bowed back, and he came down the step and went on up the road to the next house, and the woman shut the screen and went inside.

Leib stood in the road for some time. Then he turned around and walked to Lakewood.

It was after ten when he got there. The beis medrash was half full, the lights hanging low over the long tables, the sound of it coming out the open windows into the street the way it always did, two hundred voices arguing in pairs. Reb Zalman was already at his table by the radiator with his hat pushed back. He did not look up.

Leib sat down across from Avrohom Wolpe, who had waited for him, and opened the Gemara to where they had stopped in February.

• • •

The farm was sold in July. The Shas came from a bookseller on the Lower East Side in September, after the holidays, twenty volumes in dark blue cloth stamped in gold, from the good shelf. Leib set them up on two planks over cinder blocks in the front room of the apartment on Fifth Street, where Raizel had cleared a wall, and put the tallis in the drawer under them. His father's envelope he kept, with the writing on it, in the first volume, at the first page, where the Mishnah asks from what hour in the evening one may say the Shema.

Background

The verses

> *There is no satisfying lusts, even by a shower of gold pieces; he who knows that lusts have a short taste and cause pain, he is wise;*
>
> Dhammapada 186, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Even in heavenly pleasures he finds no satisfaction, the disciple who is fully awakened delights only in the destruction of all desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 187, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young monk is sent away by his preceptor to learn the rules of discipline. While he is gone his father falls ill, longs to see him, and dies talking about him, leaving a hundred coins with the youngest son "to buy a bowl and robe for my son." When the monk comes home his little brother throws himself at his feet in tears. The monk refuses the money, then begins to think that it would be enough to live on as a layman, and stops reciting and meditating until he looks jaundiced. The novices notice; his teachers bring him to the Buddha, who has him fetch pebbles and count out fifty for food and drink and twenty-four each for two oxen, seed, a plow, a spade and an adze, and the hundred coins run out. Then the Buddha tells the birth story of King Mandhātā, a world-ruler who could make it rain jewels by clapping his hands, who rose to rule the heaven of the Four Great Kings and then shared the throne of Sakka in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three while thirty-six Sakkas came and went, until he resolved to kill Sakka, aged, fell into a park on earth, and died sending word of all he had ruled. Read the full commentary story, or about Mandhātā.

Lakewood and Jackson Township, New Jersey

Ocean County, New Jersey, *1963*

Lakewood began as a fashionable winter resort in the 1880s, with great hotels in the pines and the estate of George Jay Gould on Lake Carasaljo (now Georgian Court University). The hotel trade declined badly in the 1960s, the woods and cranberry bogs gave way to housing, and the retirement community of Leisure Village opened for sale in 1963 (Lakewood Township). In 1943 Rabbi Aharon Kotler, who had led the yeshiva of Kletzk before escaping Europe, opened Beth Medrash Govoha in Lakewood with about fifteen students; by his death on November 29, 1962, it had some 250, and his funeral on the Lower East Side drew some 25,000 mourners (Aharon Kotler). Its married students are counted as its kollel. The yeshiva's people in this story are invented.

Jewish poultry farms spread across central and southern New Jersey with mortgage loans and advice from the Jewish Agricultural Society; Toms River, Lakewood and Farmingdale were early centers, and at the peak in the 1950s Jewish farmers produced about three quarters of the state's eggs (JewishGen KehilaLinks). In the late 1940s and early 1950s some thousands of Holocaust survivors, most with no farming experience, took up poultry, many of them around Vineland, and by the 1960s most had been driven out by falling prices and factory-scale farms (Aish). Then prices collapsed: one Farmingdale family remembered wholesale eggs falling from about ninety cents a dozen after the war to twenty-five cents by 1962, and selling their farm in 1966 for half what they had paid (New Jersey Jewish News). A few miles north, in Freewood Acres, Kalmyk Buddhist refugees had built temples in the 1950s; their monks are the subject of an earlier story in this series, Salt Tea. Eggs are still checked by candling, holding them to a light to see the yolk, air cell and any flaw through the shell.

After the story of a discontented bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 186 and 187), with the birth story of King Mandhātā. The original. Scripture from the Jewish Publication Society Tanakh (1917). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

14.6

The Sand Pile

> *Truly in vain is salvation hoped for from the hills, and from the multitude of mountains: truly in the LORD our God is the salvation of Israel.*
> *— Jeremiah 3:23*

I heard it told like this, under the Pinnacle.

I. The Chair

Middlesboro, Kentucky · 1991–1997

Brother Harlan Brand had preached thirty-one years at the big Baptist church on Cumberland Avenue, and for twenty-six of them he had also been the preacher of Shelburne Coal & Land. Old Lafe Shelburne had hired him to pray. He prayed at the opening of every new mine and at the funeral of every man killed in one, and on the first Monday of every month he sat in on the board and opened it, and when the old man died in 1991 it was Brother Brand who buried him.

The son kept him on. Coleman Shelburne was forty-four that year, a quiet man who had been to Vanderbilt and ate his dinner at the board table without seeming to taste it, and he did a thing his father had never done. When Brother Brand came in on the first Monday, Coleman got up from behind the desk and came around it to the door to meet him, and walked him back, and pulled out a chair for him on his own side of the desk, the same chair as his, and said, *Preacher, sit here by me.* He did it every month for six years.

Middlesboro sits in a hole in the mountains three miles across that something made when it fell out of the sky, a long time before there was anybody to see it. Brother Brand had read that in the paper the year they

found it out, and he had never forgotten it. He thought of it on the first Monday in March 1997, sitting in the chair on the right side of Coleman Shelburne's desk with the window behind him full of the town. He was seventy-one. The company had laid off four hundred men in two years. Coleman was cordial to him, and Coleman would be cordial to him until the day he was not, the way the old man had been cordial to the men he had prayed over. There was no keeping in with rich men for good and all. A chair at a man's side suited a man his own age, and Brother Brand was old.

He resigned the church at Easter and the company the same week. Then he took out a half page in the *Daily News*, and the half page said that everything Harlan Brand owned was in the yard of his house on the west end of town and would be there for seven days, free, to anyone who came and carried it off. His wife had been dead nine years. People came from three states. They took the bedroom suite and the Buick and the riding mower and his books, and the last day a family from Harrogate backed a pickup to the porch and took the porch swing off its chains, and he helped them. Then he sold the house and gave the money to the widows' fund at the company, and went up the mountain.

Some of the church went with him. More came after.

II. The Sand Pile

A hollow on the Virginia side, east of the Gap · 1998–1999

A man named Elmer Collingsworth, who had been a deacon under him, owned a hundred and sixty acres of steep woods in a hollow on the Virginia side of Cumberland Mountain, east of the Gap, and from the head of the hollow you could see the knob where Kentucky and Virginia and Tennessee come to a point at a marker in the rocks. He gave it to Brother Brand by deed. There was a creek in the bottom with a bar of clean sand on every bend, and a big rock house up the slope, a shelf of sandstone overhanging a floor as dry as a church, where people had taken shelter, Brother Brand said, since there were people.

The first summer there were thirty of them in tents and campers. Then the papers and the television began to say what would happen when the clocks turned over to the year 2000, how the computers that ran the power plants and the banks and the water would read the two zeros as 1900 and stop, and the people who came up the gravel road the second year came with generators in their pickup beds and their children's school records in a shoebox. Men who had been laid off by Shelburne came. Women whose husbands had left came. A boy named Tyler Ely came who had done a semester at Lincoln Memorial and could not afford the second one. By the fall of 1999 there were more than three hundred people in the hollow, in campers and trailers and plywood cabins along the creek, and Brother Brand had stopped preaching from the whole Bible and preached from one verse.

I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, he would say, *from whence cometh my help.* And he would lift his eyes, and they would lift theirs, to the ridge. *Get to the mountain. Get up under the rock. Get back in the big woods, under the poplars. Whoever takes to the mountain will come through it. Whoever takes to the rock will come through it.*

They met at night in the rock house, all of them, with a fire in the middle of the floor and the shelves of canned goods along the back. The fire threw their shadows up on the back wall of the rock, big and slow, a hundred heads and shoulders moving when anyone moved, and if you sat by the fire you watched the shadows more than you watched the people. Tyler Ely said once that it was like a thing in Plato he had read at Lincoln Memorial, people in a cave watching shadows on a wall and taking them for the world. Brother Brand said Plato was a heathen, kindly, and Tyler did not bring it up again. But he watched the wall.

Brother Brand gave them one rule besides the verse. Whenever one of them was troubled in his mind, after a woman who was not his, or after liquor, or after a fight with a man, or whatever it was, he was to take a five-gallon bucket down to the creek and fill it with sand and carry it up the slope and empty it on the pile at the mouth of the rock house. Brother Brand meant the pile to go over the top of the bunker they had dug for the food, to cover it, and he meant the carrying to settle a man down, and

both of these happened. Men carried at night. Women carried. A man named Darnell Cox carried eleven buckets in one evening and would not say why.

By the fall of 1999 the pile was higher than a house, and the bunker was long since covered, and it kept growing. You could stand in the hollow and see how troubled three hundred people had been for two years. It was all there, in clean creek sand.

In October a timber rattler took it. It was as long as a man was tall and as big around as a man's wrist, black down the back and yellow along the sides, and it went into the top of the pile one cold evening and stayed for the winter as if the pile had been built for it. The sand on top never froze after that, and snow would not lie on it. The people called it the Old Man. Nobody carried on that side of the pile again.

And people came from all three states to see them. On the first Saturday of every month cars and pickups came up the gravel road from Middlesboro and Harrogate and Ewing and Jonesville and as far as Pineville, people who did not live in the hollow and would not have, but wanted to have done something, and they brought canned goods and lamp oil and powdered milk and gallon jugs of water and boxes of shotgun shells and laid them down around the foot of the sand pile, on the near side, away from the Old Man. Then they stood a while and looked up at the ridge, and drove home.

III. The Lineman

Thursday, December 30, 1999

It came on to rain at dark, a cold heavy rain out of the southwest, in drops so big they rang on the trailer roofs, and the meeting in the rock house broke up early and everybody ran for their own door. Brother Brand had a single-wide at the head of the hollow, the only thing he owned. He was sitting in it with the lamp lit, because the generator was saved now for the end, when somebody knocked and called through the door.

Harlan.

Nobody had called him Harlan since Ruth died. The board had called him Brother Brand, and Coleman Shelburne had called him Preacher, and the three hundred people in the hollow called him Brother. He did not get up.

Who is that?

It's me.

What do you want?

A place to lay down tonight, out of this.

He opened the door. There was a big man on the step in a yellow rain slicker with the hood down and the rain running off his face, a man in his forties with a lineman's forearms and a lineman's ruined hands, and nothing in them. Behind him in the dark the creek was coming up.

There's no room, said Brother Brand. *There's a family in every camper on this creek.*

Harlan, miners bunk with miners, the man said, *and church folks put up church folks. You're a preacher. I'm a preacher. Give me a place.*

You're a preacher?

Old Regular. Lick Fork church, under Elder Sizemore. I've been called nine years.

Brother Brand knew of the Old Regulars. Everybody in that country did. They had no seminary and no pay and no piano, and their preachers worked in the mines and drove trucks and climbed poles all week and stood up on Sunday and preached with no notes until the Spirit let them go.

You came up here, he said, *two days before the end of the world, with nothing. Where's your Bible? Where's your gear? Where's your water?*

I don't carry it. Whatever I need, I'll get inside.

You'll get it inside, said Brother Brand, and he heard his own voice go up the way it had not gone up in years. *From us. You'll eat out of our stores.*

Harlan, said the big man, *don't get mad. Just give me a place.*

There's no place.

The man turned his head and looked down the hollow, in the rain, at the sand pile, which you could make out from there in the dark because

there was no snow on it and no shine of water. The rain went into it without a sound.

Who stays up there?

A snake.

Let me have the sand pile.

I can't let you have it. The people set store by that snake. It would be an insult to them.

Never mind that. Let me have it.

Brother Brand looked at him a long time with the rain blowing in on his feet.

Suit yourself, he said. *You seem to know.*

The man walked down the hollow in the rain and climbed the pile on the far side, the Old Man's side, where nobody had gone since October, digging the toes of his boots into the wet sand.

Everybody who was awake in the hollow saw what happened next, and afterward all of them told it the same way. The Old Man came up out of the top of the pile to meet him, more of him than anyone had known there was, and smoke came off it, gray smoke, out of its mouth and off the length of it in the rain, as if the snake were a stick of green wood on a fire. And the lineman stood on the top of the pile and smoke came off him too, the same gray smoke, out of his mouth and off his slicker and his hands, and the two smokes went up together into the rain and the rain did not touch them, and went up past the ridge into the clouds. Then the snake caught fire. It burned blue at first along the edges, and then yellow, all the length of it, so that you could see the whole sand pile lit up and the rain coming down slantwise through the light. And the man caught fire too. He lit up from the boots up the way a man lights up when a line he is working arcs, white and then yellow, until he was standing on the top of the pile like a torch, and the fire went up off him into the clouds and lit the bottoms of them, and people on the Tennessee side said afterward they had seen the clouds over the ridge go orange for a while that night and thought it was a barn.

The people in the hollow watched from their doors. *That snake's killed him,* they said to each other. *He wouldn't listen. Brother told him.* Then the

light went down, and it was dark and raining again on the sand, and nobody went to look. Tyler Ely stood a long time in his cabin door after the others had gone in, watching the place on the pile where the fire had been, and saw nothing more.

IV. The Elder

Friday, December 31, 1999

It cleared in the night and froze. In the morning the people came out to the sand pile in their coats to see whether he was dead, and he was sitting on top of it.

He was dry. The slicker was folded under him. Behind him the Old Man lay coiled in a ring on the top of the pile, all the length of him, and the snake had raised his head and the front of his body up over the man and bent it forward, and held it there, broad and still, so that it made a roof over the man's head like the roof of a porch. And around the foot of the pile, all the way around, not only on the near side, the canned goods and the jugs of water and the lamp oil and the powdered milk had been set out in rows, neat, the labels all turned out, the way a woman sets a table for a reunion.

The people stood in a ring.

Lord, mister, said Darnell Cox. *He must have give you a terrible night.*

Don't you see him? said the lineman. *He's right here.*

How did a man do that, people said to one another. *How did a man do that to that snake.* Nobody went home. They stood around the pile all morning in the cold, and somebody brought him coffee, and he drank it. His name, he told them, was Kenny Moberly, and he worked for the electric co-op, and he was supposed to be on call that night with every lineman in three states, and was not.

A little after noon an old man came walking up the gravel road from where the county road ended. He was eighty-two and moved slow, in a black suit and an overcoat, with a white shirt buttoned to the neck and no tie, the way the old men at Lick Fork dressed for meeting, and a cane he did not lean on much. When Kenny Moberly saw him he came down

off the sand pile and went down the road to meet him, and took his hand, and walked him up.

Is he bigger than you? somebody asked Kenny.

This is Elder Burl Sizemore, said Kenny. *He's my elder. I'm a member under him.*

The Elder looked at the sand pile a while, and at the snake. Then he went up it, slowly, one foot and then the cane, with Kenny behind him, and sat down on the very top in his overcoat with his hands on the head of the cane, and the Old Man moved over to give him the room and laid his head down on the sand.

The people looked at each other. *If the young one can do what he did,* they said, *what can that old man do?* Some of the women put their hands together under their chins, and a few of the men took off their caps.

Brother Brand had come down from his trailer. He stood at the foot of the pile with the rest.

Harlan, said the Elder. *What is it you tell these people?*

I tell them get to the mountain, said Brother Brand. His voice was steady and it carried, as it always had. *The hundred and twenty-first Psalm. I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help. I tell them get up under the rock. Get back in the big woods. Whoever takes to the mountain will come through.*

No, said the Elder. *They won't, Harlan.*

He did not raise his voice. He was a man who had preached sixty years with no notes and no pay and no piano, and had loaded coal for forty of them at Kettle Island, and he did not seem to need to raise it. He said the verse Brother Brand had said, and then the one after it, which Brother Brand had stopped saying, and then he said the others, in the long chanting way the Old Regulars have, where a man takes a breath and the words come out on it.

> *I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help. My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth.*
>
> *— Psalm 121:1–2*
>
> *Truly in vain is salvation hoped for from the hills, and from the multitude of mountains: truly in the LORD our God is the salvation of Israel.*
>
> *— Jeremiah 3:23*
>
> *God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble. Therefore will not we fear, though the earth be removed, and though the mountains be carried into the midst of the sea; though the waters thereof roar and be troubled, though the mountains shake with the swelling thereof.*
>
> *— Psalm 46:1–3*

He made the hills, said the Elder. *They're not where it comes from. They'll go when he's done with them, same as us.* He looked down at the people standing around the pile in their coats. *There's trouble in this world. You all know there is. And you know where it comes from in you, you've carried it up this hill in buckets for two years, I can see it from here. It can be laid down. And there's a way to walk that lays it down. That's all I know to tell you. It's the only place I ever found to stand.*

Then he said, *Come on down from here,* and he did not seem to mean only the sand pile.

• • •

Nobody went into the rock house that night. At eleven o'clock they all went up the path behind the hollow to the open place on the ridge, three hundred people with flashlights and children on their shoulders, and stood in the cold. The Elder rode up on a four-wheeler with Kenny driving. He sat on a rock, and when it was near the time he lined out a hymn, one line at a time in his old cracked voice, and the people sang each line back after him, slow, the way it is done at Lick Fork, though most of them had never been.

From the ridge you could see three states. Down to the west was Middlesboro in its crater, all lit, a bowl of lights. Off to the south were the lights of Cumberland Gap and Harrogate, and east down the long valley of the Powell were Ewing and Rose Hill and the yard lights of farms all the way to Jonesville. Somebody had a watch that beeped. At midnight there were some fireworks over Middlesboro, small from up there, and a few gunshots in the valley, and church bells from somewhere you could not tell.

The lights stayed where they were. Every one.

Tyler Ely turned around once and looked back down the hollow at the mouth of the rock house, where there was no fire tonight and nothing moving on the wall.

Nobody said anything for a long time. Then Kenny Moberly's pager went off on his belt, loud in the quiet, and he looked at it and laughed out loud. A man in Ewing had come home from a party at ten after twelve and put his truck into a pole on the Wilderness Road, and there were eleven houses dark. It was the only outage the co-op had that night. Kenny shook the Elder's hand and went down the mountain in the dark to fix it.

V. Seven Times

Saturday, January 1, 2000

In the morning the people of the hollow came out of their campers and trailers and plywood cabins dressed for church. Every one of them. Men who had not had a tie on in two years had a tie on, and women who had come up the mountain with one suitcase came out in their good dresses and stockings, and children were in their Easter clothes with their hair wet down. Nobody remembered packing any of it. Afterward nobody could say where it had come from. They stood around the sand pile in the frost, quiet and settled, three hundred of them, like people who had been members of a church sixty years and had their own pews, and the Elder sat on the top of the pile in his overcoat in the sun.

It was the first Saturday of the month.

About ten o'clock the cars began to come up the gravel road from three states with their offerings, the pickups from Harrogate and the station wagons from Pineville, people who had stayed home in their lit houses the night before and woke up feeling a little foolish, and had come anyway. They got out with their sacks of canned goods and their jugs of water and stopped. They saw the people of the hollow all dressed for church. They saw an old man none of them knew sitting on top of the sand pile with the rattler laid out in the sun beside him like a dog, and Brother Brand standing at the bottom.

Which one of them is it, they said to each other. *Is it Brother Brand, or is it that old man?* And because the old man had only just come, and they had been driving up that road for two years, they said, *It's Brother Brand.*

The Elder looked down at Brother Brand.

Harlan, he said. *Settle it for them.*

That's what I want more than anything in this world, said Brother Brand.

Then he went up into the air.

He went straight up off the sand at the foot of the pile in his overcoat, slowly, the way a man goes up a pole on his hooks, until he was as high as the top of the big poplars and the people from three states could see the soles of his shoes. Then he came down and knelt in the sand at the Elder's feet with his forehead to the sand. He did it seven times. He went up and came down and knelt, seven times, in front of everybody, and the people who had brought the offerings stood in the road with their sacks in their arms and counted. The seventh time he stayed on his knees.

He's my elder, said Harlan Brand, loud enough for all of them, with sand on his forehead. *I'm a member under him.*

• • •

Kenny Moberly came back up the hollow at noon in the co-op truck, with the man in Ewing's pole set and the eleven houses lit, and backed up to the sand pile. He took the hot stick down off the rack on the truck, the long yellow fiberglass pole linemen use to handle a live wire without touching it, and walked up the pile with it.

The Old Man let himself be lifted. He hung over the end of the hot stick in two long loops, black and yellow, with his head up and his tongue going, and Kenny carried him down the far side of the pile and up the slope past the rock house, the stick held out level in front of him, slow, to the ledges under the ridge where the rattlers in that country have always gone in for the winter. He laid the end of the stick down on the rock by a crack. The snake poured off it into the crack, all of him, the way creek water goes down into sand, until there was only the tail, and then not that.

Background

The verses

> *Men, driven by fear, go to many a refuge, to mountains and forests, to groves and sacred trees.*
>
> Dhammapada 188, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But that is not a safe refuge, that is not the best refuge; a man is not delivered from all pains after having gone to that refuge.*
>
> Dhammapada 189, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

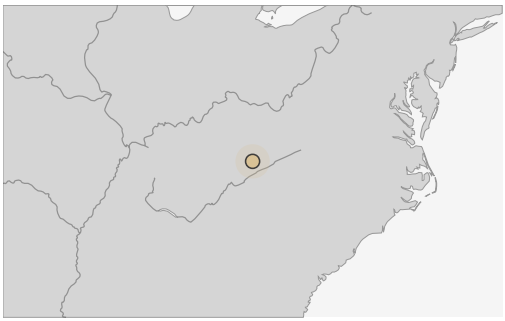
> *He who takes refuge with Buddha, the Law, and the Church; he who, with clear understanding, sees the four holy truths:—*
>
> Dhammapada 190, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Viz. pain, the origin of pain, the destruction of pain, and the eightfold holy way that leads to the quieting of pain;—*
>
> Dhammapada 191, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *That is the safe refuge, that is the best refuge; having gone to that refuge, a man is delivered from all pain.*
>
> Dhammapada 192, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the brahmin Aggidatta is chaplain to King Mahā Kosala and then to his son Pasenadi, who seats him as an equal. Knowing that the favor of kings does not last, the old man gives away his wealth in a week and goes forth, and ten thousand follow him to a place on the frontier of three countries. There he teaches that refuge in a mountain, a forest, a grove or a tree frees a person from all suffering, and has his followers carry a jar of river sand to one spot whenever a sensual thought

troubles them. The heap grows great, a nāga king takes it for his own, and the people of the three countries bring offerings every month. The Buddha sends Mahā Moggallāna ahead. In a storm he asks Aggidatta for lodging, is refused, asks for the sand heap instead, and overcomes the nāga in a contest of smoke and fire; in the morning he sits on the heap under the serpent's hood. The Buddha arrives, sits on the summit, and answers Aggidatta's teaching with the verses. The followers go forth, and when the people arrive with offerings and wonder which teacher is greater, Aggidatta rises seven times into the air and declares himself the Buddha's disciple. Read the full commentary story, or about Moggallāna.



Cumberland Gap, Virginia

Cumberland Gap, *1999*

The Year 2000 problem was the fear that computers storing years in two digits would read 2000 as 1900 and fail. Some people stocked food, water and guns, bought generators and drew out cash; interest in survivalism peaked in 1999, and some preachers tied the date to the end times. The United States spent an estimated $134 billion on preparation, and when the clocks turned over the failures were few and minor. January 1, 2000, fell on a Saturday.

Kentucky, Virginia and Tennessee meet at Tri-State Peak, inside Cumberland Gap National Historical Park. Just to the west, Middlesboro was founded in 1886 inside the Middlesboro crater, a meteorite impact basin about three miles wide that geologists identified in the 1960s. The Old Regular Baptists, most numerous along the Kentucky–Virginia border, have preachers who are called rather than trained and serve without pay, sing their hymns lined out and unaccompanied, and baptize in running water. Brother Brand, Shelburne Coal & Land, the hollow, Lick Fork church and all the people are invented.

After the story of the brahmin Aggidatta from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 188–192). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

14.7

Sire and Dam

> *Man scans with scrupulous care the character and pedigree of his horses, cattle, and dogs before he matches them; but when he comes to his own marriage he rarely, or never, takes any such care.*
> — *Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man, ch. XXI*

The way it was given me, at Fenwick.

I. The Private Book

Elm Lawn, east of Fenwick, Iowa · April 1896

The heifer came a little before four, in the box stall at the south end of the cow barn, and by the time there was light to see her color she was on her feet and had found the bag. Felix rubbed her off with a grain sack and stood back. She was roan, a deep strawberry roan like her dam, level along the top, with a white switch to her tail. He watched her suck until he was sure of her. Then he went up to the house, washed to the elbows at the kitchen pump, and sat down in the office off the kitchen to write her in the book.

Mrs. Rusk kept two. One was the American Herd Book, some forty volumes along the top shelf, which belonged to the Association in Chicago and told the world what her cattle were. The other was a canvas-backed ledger as thick as a pulpit Bible, and she called it the private book. Every animal calved at Elm Lawn since 1867 had a page in it. At the top of the page went the sire and the dam. Under them was a ruled space headed *Remarks*, and into it, over the years, went whatever the animal did: its weights, its calves, the price it fetched, and what she had seen with

her own eyes. *Slack back of the shoulder. Milks like a Jersey. Sold to Gaddis; I would not have kept her.*

He wrote:

> Roan heifer, calved April 16, 1896. Sire, Scottish Baron, bred at Elm Lawn, by Craigie, imported. Dam, Elm Lawn Lavender 6th, by Craigie; second dam, Lavender 4th. Both tracing to Champion of England, bred by A. Cruickshank, Sittyton, Aberdeenshire.

He did not have to look any of it up. He had kept the book four years, and he had the herd by heart to the sixth dam, the way other young men around Fenwick had the batting averages of the Chicago nine.

He had more than the herd. Mrs. Rusk talked while she worked, and what she talked was blood. From her he knew that the big gray drafters came out of the Perche, a district of France you could lose in three Iowa counties, and that the best of them on this side of the water went back to a black horse called Brilliant that Mr. Dunham had stood at Oaklawn, in Illinois. He knew that every trotter worth a second look came down from one bay stallion, Hambletonian, foaled in Orange County, New York. He knew that the Poland-China hog had been made in two counties of Ohio, Butler and Warren, between the Miami rivers, and that Mrs. Rusk had been made in Butler County herself, a fact she brought up about as often as she brought up the hog. And he knew that the thick red and roan cattle in her own pasture, low to the ground and quick to finish, came from a single rented farm in Aberdeenshire, where a man named Cruickshank had bred them for fifty years by looking at the cattle and letting the paper look after itself.

She had her reasons for telling it that way. Tobias Rusk had bought paper. In 1873 a cow of the Duchess family was knocked down at New York Mills for forty thousand six hundred dollars, and half the Shorthorn men in the country lost their heads, Tobias with them. He put a mortgage on the east quarter for two heifers of the fashionable blood. One was a shy breeder and the other never dropped a living calf. When he died in 1884 the bank held paper on the land and the cattle both. His widow sold the fashionable ones by the pound. She kept the plainest, thickest cows on

the place, among them two of the old Kentucky sort that the fancy called Seventeens and would not have in a sale ring, because their line ran back to an importation of 1817 and stopped there with no page behind it. Over them she put a Scotch bull out of a herd in Kansas, bought with the last of the insurance.

I quit buying names, she said, when anybody asked how she had held on.

Felix had no page. He had come into Fenwick on the cars in October of 1884, eight years old or near it, one of a company of twenty from the Children's Aid Society in New York, with a card pinned to his jacket that gave a number and the one word *Felix*. He had sat on the stage of the opera house with the others. A farmer named Gault from the north end of the county took him, and got eight years of chores out of him, and gave him about two winters of school. One September, at sixteen, Felix walked south until dark and went to sleep in the first shed that had straw in it. Mrs. Rusk found him there in the morning among her weanling calves. She looked at him for some time. Then she asked him whether he could write a plain hand.

He blotted the heifer's line. The space under *Remarks* was empty, as it was on every new page.

Out in the kitchen she was pinning on her town hat. A handbill lay on the table, the same one that had been in the post office window for two weeks. Another company was coming on the noon train, eleven boys and three girls. Mr. Hallam of the Society would speak at the opera house at half past two, and persons wishing a child were to give their names to the committee. The committee was the Methodist minister, Dr. Vance, the cashier of the bank, the editor of the *Reporter*, and Mrs. Rusk. They had put her on, the first woman they ever had, because there was not a man in the county who would argue with her eye.

Hitch the grays, she said. *You may as well see it from the other side.*

II. The Opera House

Fenwick · that afternoon

THE CHAIRS HAD BEEN BORROWED FROM THE ODD FELLOWS and set in a row across the stage, in front of a painted drop of a lake nobody in Fenwick had ever seen. The children sat with their hands in their laps. They had been washed at the hotel and their hair was still wet. Mr. Hallam, a spare man with a carrying voice, stood at the footlights and gave the terms as he had given them in two hundred towns. Boys under twelve were to stay until eighteen and be treated in schooling, clothing and training as the family's own. Boys of twelve to fifteen were to have board and clothes until seventeen, and school a part of every year. The Society paid the fare, and could take a child back for cause.

Then the people came up the side steps, and Felix, standing at the back by the stove, saw what he remembered.

A man took a boy's upper arm between his thumb and two fingers and worked down it to the wrist. Another said *Open* and looked at a boy's teeth, tipping the chin toward the window. A woman turned a girl around by the shoulders, looked at her from behind, and turned her back. They were not hard people. Most of them he knew. A woman from out by the creamery got down on her knees in her good dress to button a child's shoe, and stayed down there talking to him. But it was the way they went round the pens on sale day, and nobody in the hall, on the stage or off it, seemed to know another way to go about it.

Lute Achenbach came across the stage with his hat in his hand. He farmed four hundred acres and had bought his herd bull from Elm Lawn as a calf.

Adelia. You picked that bull for me at nine days old and I never had a better. Pick me a boy.

I can't do it, Lute.

You can tell me which is sound.

I can tell you which one has had the rickets and which two have been hungry lately, and so can Mr. Hallam. You're asking me the other thing. Which one will turn out.

With a calf you know.

With a calf I have the sire and the dam and three crosses behind them written down, and I have my eyes, and I am wrong one time in three. She looked along the row of chairs. *These have no paper at all. If they had it I would not know how to read it.*

Achenbach laughed, because he thought she was being modest, and went back along the row by himself.

At the far end a boy of ten or so was standing. He had given his chair to a smaller girl who had none, and when a man reached for his arm he said, loud enough for the hall, *That's my sister. We go the both of us or we don't go.* The man went on to the next chair. By four o'clock the two of them were the only ones left on the stage. The hall was emptying and Mr. Hallam had his watch out. They went, at the last, with the Lindahls, who had put their name down for one girl to help in the house, and who stood a long time whispering before Mrs. Lindahl nodded.

Felix brought the team around. He sat on the wagon seat with the lines slack in his hands, waiting for the committee to finish its papers, and it came to him as plainly as if somebody had asked it aloud. She had told him where every well-bred thing came from. The gray horses out of the Perche, the trotters from Hambletonian, the hogs from between the Miamis, the cattle from Sittyton. In four years she had never once said where the good men came from.

III. The Lamp

Elm Lawn · that night

He asked her after supper, in the office, when she had the lamp lit and the private book open at the new page to see what he had put.

Mrs. Rusk. The well-bred men. Where do they come from?

She did not look up. *Butler County, Ohio.*

He waited.

The Miami Valley. It runs about a hundred miles, top to bottom. My father held that all the good people in the United States came out of it, and he was

from there. She turned a page back and forward again. *And not out of every house in it, either. I knew most of the houses. One. Two, if you count my aunt.*

Then she got up and took a brown book down from beside the herd books. It was Mr. Darwin's *Descent of Man*, the New York printing. Tobias had bought it the winter before he died, she said, to find out how to breed a better steer. He had underlined one sentence near the end, about how a man will scan the pedigree of his horses and cattle and dogs with scrupulous care before he matches them, and take no such care over his own marriage. She did not read him that. She found a place in the middle with no mark on it, and read it under the lamp in the voice she used for sale catalogues.

> *He who was ready to sacrifice his life, as many a savage has been, rather than betray his comrades, would often leave no offspring to inherit his noble nature. The bravest men, who were always willing to come to the front in war, and who freely risked their lives for others, would on an average perish in larger numbers than other men.*
>
> *— Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man, ch. V*

So there is no line of them, she said. *He looked as hard as a man can look. You cannot get one by matching, and when you have one you can't count on him to leave you another. They are scarce, Felix. One is dropped here and one there, in a house nobody would have picked, and the next may be four counties off and forty years on.*

She turned back a few leaves.

> *Now, if some one man in a tribe, more sagacious than the others, invented a new snare or weapon, or other means of attack or defence, the plainest self-interest, without the assistance of much reasoning power, would prompt the other members to imitate him; and all would thus profit.*
>
> *— Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man, ch. V*

That is the only way I know to tell, she said. *Afterward, and by the house. You know a bull by his get. You know that kind by everybody who lived under the*

same roof with him, kin or no kin, down to the hired girl and the stock. They all do better than they had any right to, and most of them never work out why.

She put Mr. Darwin back on the shelf. Then she drew the private book to her and turned to the very back, to the pages he had never had any call to look at, where she cast up the place once a year. She ran her finger down a column. She turned the book around on the desk so that it faced him, took the hand lamp, and went up to bed.

It was all in her own figures. For 1885 and 1886 and 1887, and on down through 1891, the year's balance was written in red ink. At 1892 the line said *Even*. The three years after it were in black, each larger than the one before. In the margin against 1892, small, in pencil, she had written *F. came, Sept.*

He sat a while with the big lamp. Then he turned the book back to the front, to the roan heifer. Sire and dam stood at the top of her page in his own plain hand, six crosses deep. Under *Remarks* there was nothing yet, and he left the pen where it lay.

Background

The verse

> *A supernatural person (a Buddha) is not easily found, he is not born everywhere. Wherever such a sage is born, that race prospers.*
>
> Dhammapada 193, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is a few lines long. The elder Ānanda, sitting alone in the afternoon, reflects that the Buddha has told the monks where well-bred elephants, horses and bullocks come from, each from a named stock or country, and has never said where well-bred people come from. He goes and asks. The Buddha answers that such people are not born everywhere, only in the Middle Country (his own homeland), and there only in a household here and there, and he gives the verse: the noble one is hard to find, and the family he is born into thrives. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda.

Fenwick, Iowa

Iowa, 1896

Between 1854 and 1929 the Children's Aid Society of New York and other charities sent some 200,000 city children west by rail to be placed in farm homes, a movement later called the orphan trains. A company would be advertised by handbill, a committee of local citizens took the names of applicants, and the children were shown on the stage of an opera house, church or skating rink. The terms Mr. Hallam recites are those printed in an Iowa newspaper notice of 1890, "Boys Wanting Homes". Riders remembered being handled like stock, and brothers and sisters were often parted. Fenwick and its people are invented.

The cattle history is real. The Shorthorn was the first breed of cattle to have a herd book, and in the 1870s American breeders bid pedigrees of the Duchess family up to a peak of $40,600 for one cow at New York Mills in 1873; the boom ended in ruin, and the plain, thick "Scotch" cattle of Amos Cruickshank's Sittyton herd took over the breed. Cattle descended from the Kentucky importation of 1817, the "Seventeens," were long slighted for want of a long pedigree, as Alvin Sanders tells in *Short-Horn Cattle* (1900). The Percheron sire Brilliant and the Poland China hog of the Miami Valley are as Felix has them. Darwin drew on breeders throughout his work; the passages Mrs. Rusk reads are from chapter V of *The Descent of Man* (second edition, 1874), where he doubts that the noblest human qualities could ever have been multiplied by selection.

After the story of Ānanda's question from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 193). The original. Scripture from Charles Darwin, The Descent of Man (second edition, 1874). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

14.8

Mic Check

Behold, how good and how pleasant it is
For brethren to dwell together in unity!
— Psalm 133:1

Mic check, this is how I heard it, in Liberty Square.

I. The Two Hours

Zuccotti Park, Lower Manhattan · October 2011

Nadège Pierre-Louis had played the djembe in the drum circle at the west end of the park since the second week, when she came down from Flatbush on her day off from the home care agency to see what the noise was about and stayed until two in the morning. She was twenty-four. She had bought the drum on Canal Street for sixty dollars the year before and taught herself on YouTube, in her bedroom, with a towel over the skin so her grandmother could sleep. At Zuccotti there was no towel. The circle went eight and ten hours a day, and when it was going the whole park leaned toward it, and people who had never danced in their lives danced on the granite, and she would look up after an hour and find the sky had gone dark over Broadway without her noticing.

The neighbors could not sleep. They went to the community board to say so, and some of them came into the park and stood in the stack at the General Assembly and waited their turn: a man from Liberty Street with a baby who would not go down, a woman who worked nights and slept days, an old man in a bathrobe under his coat. Community Board 1 voted to back the occupation and asked the drummers to keep it to two hours a day. Some of the drummers said they would play four if they were told

two, and said it loud. In the end the circle settled on two sessions of two hours.

Nadège stood at the back of the Assembly that night and listened to the old man in the bathrobe through the people's mic, his sentences coming back to her in pieces from three rings of strangers, *I have lived here forty years*, *I have lived here forty years*, *I am on your side*, *I am on your side*, *I would like to sleep*, *I would like to sleep*. When he finished, people all over the plaza held up their hands and wiggled their fingers at him, which was how you said *yes, I hear you*, and she did it too. After that she came to the park without the drum most days. When she brought it she played one session, never two, and the rest of the time she carried trays for the kitchen.

II. The Best Thing

The kitchen · Saturday, October 29

On Friday the fire department came with the police and took the generators and the gas cans, six generators and a dozen cans, for safety, they said. The media tent went dark and the kitchen went cold. The bicycles that were supposed to make the electricity were still on their way from Boston. On Saturday it snowed, in October, which almost nobody in New York had ever seen, wet heavy snow that piled on the blue tarps until they sagged and dumped it on whoever was underneath. By dark there were three inches on the granite and the park smelled of wet wool and wet cardboard.

About twenty of them ended up in the kitchen that night because it was the only place with a tarp that did not leak. They sat on milk crates and food-bank boxes in their coats and the donated blankets, eating cold peanut butter on cold bread, and somebody asked the question people ask when they are too cold to sleep.

What's the best thing? In the world. Honestly.

Rob Szymanski said power. He had been a corporal in Anbar and had come home to a foreclosure. He did not mean the bad kind. He meant the day they were the ones the city had to listen to, the day somebody at

Brookfield or City Hall picked up the phone and asked what Liberty Square wanted and then did it. *That,* he said. *Being the ones who decide. Nothing beats that.*

Leah, who was writing a dissertation she had not touched since September, said love. She had met Danny in the stack at the Assembly on the fourth night, both of them waiting to speak, and they had said the same thing in a row and laughed, and now they shared a tent by the library. *You can keep power,* she said. Danny put his face in her hair.

Biscuit said food. He had been a line cook at a place in midtown until it closed, and he ran the kitchen's night shift, and he said the best thing in the world was a hot plate of rice and beans handed to somebody who has been standing in the snow all day, and the look on their face when they take it, and he said it so hungrily that everybody laughed, and then he said they would see who laughed when the bikes came.

The argument went round. Somebody said power was what they were there to take apart. Somebody said love was just food you could talk to. Rob said Biscuit could have his rice and beans in the new world after it was won. It got sharp in the way things got sharp that week, with the generators gone and the cold and the cops on the corner and everyone knowing, without saying so, that the city was going to come for the park sooner or later.

Nadège came in from the snow with the drum on her back in a garbage bag. She had not played that day. She stamped her boots and stood under the edge of the tarp and listened for a while.

What y'all talking about?

They told her. Power, love, food. Which was best.

III. The People's Mic

The same night

SHE SET THE DRUM DOWN ON A CRATE AND PULLED THE garbage bag off it and did not play it.

That's all the same thing, she said. *You get it and you want it again tomorrow. Biscuit, how many plates you hand out? Every one of them was hungry*

again by night. She looked at Rob. *And they pick up the phone, and then what? You want them to pick it up again.*

Nobody said anything. Snow slid off the tarp outside with a sound like a sack dropped.

You want to know the best thing I saw in this park, she said. *I saw a man come in here the first week so mad he couldn't talk, and I saw him three weeks later sitting by the library like somebody turned the lights on in him. That's one. Two is when somebody stands up in the Assembly and says the true thing, and you hear it come back to you from all those mouths and you know it's true. Three is the night the man in the bathrobe said he wanted to sleep, and the whole plaza put their hands up for him. That's the best thing. Everybody together and nobody fighting.* She put her palm flat on the drumhead. *And four is staying in it. That's the hard one.*

Then she said, in the voice they used at the Assembly, *Mic check.*

Out of habit, twenty voices answered her. *Mic check.*

She gave it to them a phrase at a time, the way the people's mic worked, the way her grandmother used to read the Psalms to her in the kitchen on Rogers Avenue, slowly, in pieces, waiting for the child to say each one back. Each piece came back to her from the crates and boxes, a little ragged at first and then together.

> *Behold, how good and how pleasant it is*
> *For brethren to dwell together in unity!*
> *It is like the precious oil upon the head,*
> *That ran down upon the beard,*
> *Even Aaron's beard;*
> *That came down upon the skirt of his garments;*
> *Like the dew of Hermon,*
> *That cometh down upon the mountains of Zion:*
> *For there Jehovah commanded the blessing,*
> *Even life for evermore.*
>
> *— Psalm 133:1–3*

Rob said it back with the rest of them, every phrase. Afterward he said he had not been to church since boot camp and could not have told you

what Hermon was. He said that halfway through it he stopped hearing the words come out of his own mouth separate from anybody else's, and that was the thing he remembered. Leah said the same, in other words, in a paper she published three years later about something else. Biscuit did not say anything about it, ever, but he got up when it was over and lit the little butane burner they kept for coffee and heated rice and beans from the cooler, a pot at a time, for twenty people, and nobody argued about who got the first plate.

They were quiet after that, the whole tent. People said later that it was the quietest the kitchen ever was, quieter than the hours before dawn, and that it was warm under the tarp for a while, though the snow kept coming. Then Rob and Danny went out with brooms and knocked the snow off every sagging tarp along the east side of the park, one after another, so it would not fall on anyone sleeping.

The bicycles came from Boston a few days later. Biscuit put the first one by the kitchen and anyone who wanted a hot plate rode it for ten minutes first, and people lined up to ride.

IV. Fifty-Seventh Street

November 15, 2011, and after

The police came a little after one in the morning on the fifteenth of November, with the sanitation trucks behind them. They gave people a few minutes to leave. Then they took the park apart. The tents went into the trucks, and the kitchen, and the bicycles, and the library, five thousand books, thrown into dumpsters and garbage trucks with the wet sleeping bags. About two hundred people were arrested. By morning the granite had been power-washed, and there were barricades around it.

Nadège was in Flatbush that night, asleep, with the drum under her bed. She heard about it at six from her phone.

The kitchen crew never got the kitchen back together. Rob went to work on the Sandy relief a year later out of a church in Sunset Park, running a warehouse of donated blankets, and the people who worked with

him said he never once raised his voice. Leah finished her dissertation. Biscuit cooked at a soup kitchen in the Bronx. When any of them ran into each other, anywhere, one of them would sometimes say *mic check* under their breath, and the other would say it back.

The city said the books had been taken to the sanitation garage on Fifty-Seventh Street and could be picked up there. The library people went with boxes. They came back with twenty-six boxes, and of the five thousand books, about eight hundred were whole enough to keep. Nadège went with them, because she had a free afternoon and strong arms. In the back of the garage, in a cage of things nobody had claimed, under a heap of soaked blankets and a broken tent pole, she found a djembe in a garbage bag with its skin split. It was not hers. She carried it out anyway.

She never fixed it. It sat in the corner of her room in Flatbush for years, with the split skin, beside the good one. Some nights, when her grandmother was asleep, she sat on the edge of the bed with the good drum between her knees and laid both palms flat on the head, and did not strike it, and felt the trucks go by on Flatbush Avenue come up through the skin into her hands.

Background

The verse

> *Happy is the arising of the awakened, happy is the teaching of the True Law, happy is peace in the church, happy is the devotion of those who are at peace.*
>
> Dhammapada 194, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred monks sitting in the hall at Jetavana argue over what the best thing in the world is. Some say the pleasure of ruling, some the pleasures of love, some the pleasure of eating rice and meat. The Buddha comes in, asks what they are talking about, and tells them that all of these belong to the round of suffering, and that the good things are the arising of a Buddha, the hearing of the Dhamma, and harmony in the Sangha. He speaks the verse, and the monks reach arahantship. Read the full commentary story.

Lower Manhattan, New York

Zuccotti Park, 2011

Occupy Wall Street began in Zuccotti Park, which the occupiers called Liberty Square, on September 17, 2011. It was governed by a General Assembly that worked by modified consensus, with speakers queued in a "stack." Because the city required permits for amplified sound, the occupiers used the human or people's microphone, the crowd repeating each phrase of a speaker so those farther back could hear. The park's drum circle became a sore point with residents, and in October, Community Board 1 voted to back the occupation while asking for drumming to be limited to two hours a day. On October 28 fire marshals removed six generators and the gasoline, and the occupiers turned to bicycle-powered generators. The next day the Halloween nor'easter dropped 2.9 inches of snow on Central Park, a record for October.

Shortly after midnight on November 15, police cleared the park and arrested about two hundred people. The People's Library, which had grown from a single cardboard box to 5,554 catalogued books, was loaded into sanitation trucks. Mayor Bloomberg said the books could be retrieved from the sanitation garage on 57th Street; the librarians recovered twenty-six boxes, of which 802 books were usable. The kitchen crew and Nadège are invented. Psalm 133 is quoted from the American Standard Version (1901).

After the story of a company of bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 194). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

14.9

Summer Fallow

> *Surely, then, we must ascribe honour to the living temples of God, the living tabernacles of God.*
> *— John of Damascus, Exposition of the Orthodox Faith IV.15*

Tak ia chuv, on the Whitford road.

I. The Cross

North of Vegreville, Alberta · June 1918

The company from Pruth district set out on the Wednesday before the Feast of the Holy Trinity to walk the twenty-two miles to Cheremosh, where a new church with three domes was to be blessed on the Sunday. There were forty-one of them. They carried birch and poplar branches for the green feast and a banner of the Mother of God on two poles, and the old women carried their icons from home wrapped in embroidered towels, the way they had carried them across the ocean in 1898. At the front walked the dyak, Fedir Ilashchuk, who was sixty-seven and had been the nearest thing to a priest that Pruth district had for twenty years: he sang the services when no priest came, which was most Sundays, and read the Epistle and the Psalms, and buried the dead, and taught the boys the responses. Once a month he also walked into Vegreville and signed the book at the Mounted Police barracks, because he had been born a subject of the Austrian emperor, and there was a war.

That June the colony was quarrelling. It had begun at the reading halls and gone on to the churches, and by summer half the families north of Vegreville did not greet the other half on the road. It was over priests and bishops and who owned the church buildings and which way to make the

sign of the cross, and under that it was over older things nobody could name any longer. The dyak had his opinions and did not say them.

At noon on the first day they came to the corner of the Danylchuk place, where a tall cross of white-painted tamarack stood in a little square of fence at the edge of the field, with the slanting footboard near the bottom and a ribbon tied to it, faded to no color. The dyak stopped there. They all stopped. The old women took their icons out of the towels and stood them against the fence, and the company sang the Trisagion, and then they sat down in the grass along the road allowance to eat their bread and onions.

Out in the field, Yurko Danylchuk was plowing summer fallow behind four horses, a quarter-mile of black turned up behind him and the gulls following. The dyak sent his grandson Andrii, twelve, to ask whether the man would come and drink a little water with them.

Danylchuk came. He left the team standing and walked across the furrows, a big man with his shirt stuck to him, and when he came to the fence he took off his hat and crossed himself three times toward the cross and kissed the post and stood a moment with his head down. He did not take his hat off to the dyak, or to the old women, or to anybody in that company. He put it back on and stood there in front of them, waiting to see what they wanted. He was one of the other church. These days you did not greet across that line.

The dyak looked at him with great interest.

How do you regard this place, Pane Danylchuk?

My father found him here, said Danylchuk. *Father Kassian. In the snow, in '99, with the little box of the Holy Gifts inside his coat. My father put up the cross, and every man in my family has taken his hat off at this corner since. It came down to us. That's why.*

You do well, said the dyak. *You do well to honor it.*

Danylchuk looked at him a moment longer, and nodded once, and went back across his furrows to his horses.

The company did not like it. Petro Hudyma, who carried one pole of the banner, said what several of them were thinking. *He walked past you, Pane Dyak. He walked past all of us as if we were fence posts. And you praised*

him. And Marusia Sorochan, who had been a girl in the old country when Father Kassian was a young monk, said she did not see what a man of the other church was doing with their Father Kassian at all.

The dyak sat down again in the grass and broke his bread.

Andrii, he said. *Bring me the water. I will tell you who is under that cross, and then you can say whether the man did well.*

II. The Potter

On the Cheremosh, in the old country · 1871

When I was nineteen, the dyak said, I was the cleverest young man on the Cheremosh, and the most foolish. I had been to school in Vyzhnytsia for two winters. I read newspapers. I thought priests were for old women and monks were for nobody.

My friend was Hnat the potter, from across the river below Pistyn. Hnat made pots and jugs and bowls, green and yellow on white, the best on that river, and he made them in a strange way. He would not dig his clay with a spade. He said he did not want to cut through anything living to get it. He took only what the river had already torn out of the bank in the spring flood, or what the moles had thrown up in the meadow, and that was all the clay he ever had, and somehow it was always enough.

His father and mother were both blind, and he kept them. He did not take his pots to the fair at Kuty to sell. He set them out on a bench by the road in front of his house, and anybody who needed a pot took one, and left what they liked, a little flour, a few eggs, a coin, nothing. Every evening Hnat carried in whatever had been left and cooked it for the old people, and put out more pots.

Up the hill above Hnat's house there was a little wooden church and a monk who served it, Father Kassian, who was young then, younger than I am now by forty years. Hnat loved him. When Father Kassian came down the hill and Hnat was away, the blind parents would call out, *Father, there is soup in the pot, and bread under the cloth, take what you want,* and he would sit down at their table and eat, and when Hnat came home and saw

the bowl he would laugh out loud and say, *He has been here. He trusted me enough to eat without asking.*

That autumn the roof of the little church began to leak over the altar. There was no money for shingles. While Hnat was away at the Kuty fair, buying a horse for a neighbor, Father Kassian's people came down the hill and asked the blind parents, and the old woman said, *Take them, take them, the roof is his,* and they climbed up on Hnat's house and took off his shingles and carried them up the hill and put them on the church. When Hnat came home, his house had no roof. He stood in the road and laughed until he had to sit down.

It rained that whole autumn on the Cheremosh. Three months. It rained on every roof on that river and in through every bad shingle and down every chimney. In Hnat's house, with no roof on it, the floor stayed dry. The blind old people sat by the stove and felt the sky over them with their faces, and not a drop came in. People came from three villages to stand in his doorway and look up at the rain stopping in the air above his rafters.

I did not go to look. I said it was a story for old women.

Hnat asked me many times to come up the hill with him and hear Father Kassian. I always said, *What do I want with looking at a monk?* At last one day by the river he asked me again and I said it again, and Hnat, who was the gentlest man I ever knew, took hold of me by my hair. I wore it long then, like everybody. He took hold of it in his fist and walked me up the hill like a calf, the whole way, with me shouting, and the whole village came out to see, because nobody in that village had ever seen Hnat lay a hand on anything that was alive. He walked me in at the church door and let go.

Father Kassian was sitting on the step inside, mending a censer chain. He looked up at me with my hair every which way and said, *Sit down, Fedia. You must be tired.* That was all. I sat down.

The dyak drank his water.

I never went back to Vyzhnytsia. I learned the eight tones from him and the order of the services. When our families came to this country he came after us, though nobody had sent for him, because there was no

priest here at all. He went from district to district on foot, in all weathers, with the Holy Gifts in a little box inside his coat. In the second winter they found him at this corner, sitting in the snow as if he had only stopped to rest. Hnat would not come to Canada; he said his parents were too old to cross the water. So I am the one who carries this.

He took a bundle out of his bag and unwrapped it on his knee, a worn embroidered towel, and inside it a priest's stole, old brocade gone brown, with the gold thread rubbed through to the linen at the neck.

There are three kinds of holy places, he said. *The place where a holy man's bones are. The cross or the picture that stands for him. And a thing he used.* He laid one hand on the stole, and pointed with the other at the cross in its fence, and at the field. *Two of them are here. So when a man takes off his hat at that corner, I say he does well. I don't care what church he goes to.*

III. The Living Icons

The Danylchuk corner · the same afternoon

What happened next was told for fifty years in Pruth district and Cheremosh and all the districts north of Vegreville, and the people who told it did not all go to the same church, and they told it the same way.

The dyak stood up and looked out over the summer fallow, and the company looked where he was looking, and Danylchuk out at the far end of his field stopped his team and looked too. Over the black field, in the white heat of the afternoon, there was a church standing in the air. It was the little wooden church on the hill above the Cheremosh, the same one, every board of it, with the potter's shingles on the roof; but it was gold, all of it, and it was as tall as a mountain, so that the poplar bluffs at the edge of the field came only to the bottom step of it. It stood on nothing. Its domes were in the clouds, and the light came off it so that the gulls behind Danylchuk's plow were gold too.

The old women went down on their knees in the road.

The dyak did not kneel. He turned his back on the gold church, and with his open hand he showed them the company itself: the old women

on their knees with their icons, Marusia Sorochan who had buried four children in this ground, Petro Hudyma whose hands were split from building the church at Cheremosh log by log, the widow Paraska who had fed every new family off the train since 1899 and never been thanked, the boys who knew the responses, Andrii with the empty cup.

In church, he said, *when the priest comes out with the censer, first he censes the icons. Then he turns around and censes you. Did you ever wonder why? Look at that,* he said, pointing over his shoulder without looking, *and then look at each other. It is a good thing to bow to a cross. It is a better thing to bow to people like these.*

And then he said it the way he had learned it from Father Kassian, out of the old book of Saint John of Damascus, the same John who wrote the hymns they sang over their dead.

> *Surely, then, the worshippers and friends and sons of God are to be held in honour? For the honour shewn to the most thoughtful of fellow-servants is a proof of good feeling towards the common Master.*
>
> *Surely, then, we must ascribe honour to the living temples of God, the living tabernacles of God.*
>
> *Let us raise monuments to them and visible images, and let us ourselves become, through imitation of their virtues, living monuments and images of them.*
>
> *— John of Damascus, Exposition of the Orthodox Faith IV.15 (tr. S. D. F. Salmond)*

And who will count what that is worth, said the dyak, *to honor even one of them? Nobody. Not the bishop. Not the government. Nobody can say, it is so much and no more.*

Out in the field, Yurko Danylchuk took off his hat. He took it off, people said, not to the gold church in the air but to the old women in the road, and to the dyak, and he stood like that by his horses until the company picked up its banner and went on north.

IV. Seven Days

North of Vegreville · summer 1918

The gold church stood over the Danylchuk summer fallow for seven days.

People came from Andrew and Whitford and Hairy Hill and Mundare, and from as far as Smoky Lake with their wagons, Catholic and Orthodox and the ones who were not sure any longer which they were, and they stood along the road allowance and in the plowed ground, and the old women sang, and somebody always had bread. An English rancher came from beyond Vegreville and said it was a mirage, that the prairie did that in the heat, lifting some town from over the horizon up into the sky, and then he stood and looked at it all afternoon with his hat in his hand like everybody else. Two Mounted Policemen rode out to see what the crowd was about and did not write anything down.

That was the summer the men from all three provinces met in Saskatoon to start a church of their own, and after that the quarrel in the colony did not end for thirty years. But for those seven days it was said that nobody on the Whitford road refused anybody else a cup of water.

On the seventh evening the gold church went back the way it had come, east, and was not there. In the place where it had stood, at the corner of the field by the white cross, there was the heap of stones that the Danylchuks had been picking off that field for twenty years, every spring, rock by rock, gray and pink and black, and carrying to the corner on a stoneboat, until it was taller than a man. Everybody had driven past it a thousand times. That evening, people said, with the sun going down behind it, you could see it had the shape of a church.

The next spring Yurko Danylchuk and his sons built a little chapel at the corner out of those stones, with one small dome of tin on top, and the dyak of Pruth district came and sang at the blessing of it, and Danylchuk took off his hat to him at the door. The chapel is still there, though the field has been sold twice. People of both churches stop at it. The tamarack cross has been replaced with iron, and inside, on a shelf under the window, there is an old priest's stole wrapped in an embroidered towel,

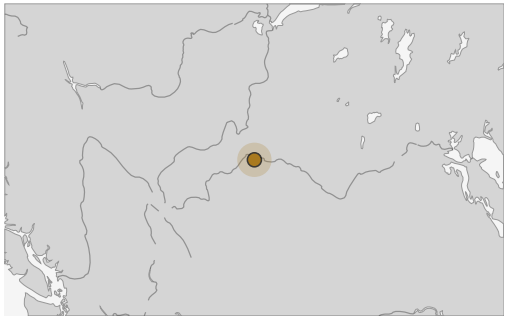
and a green-and-yellow jug from the old country with a chip out of the lip that nobody can remember bringing.

Background

The verses

> *He who pays homage to those who deserve homage, whether the awakened (Buddha) or their disciples, those who have overcome the host (of evils), and crossed the flood of sorrow, he who pays homage to such as have found deliverance and know no fear, his merit can never be measured by anybody.*
>
> Dhammapada 195–196, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha, traveling toward Bārāṇasī with a great company of monks, sits down at an old shrine near the village of Todeyya and sends Ānanda to call a brahmin who is plowing nearby. The brahmin bows to the shrine and not to the Buddha, and explains that the shrine has come down to him through the generations. The Buddha praises him. When the monks are puzzled, he tells the story of the potter Ghaṭīkāra (Majjhima Nikāya 81): supporter of the earlier Buddha Kassapa, keeper of his blind parents, a man who dug no earth and let anyone take his pots, whose roof thatch was taken for the Buddha's hut while no rain fell into his house for three months, and who dragged his proud friend Jotipāla (the future Gotama) by the hair to meet Kassapa. Then the Buddha makes a golden double of Kassapa's shrine appear in the air, a league high, points to his monks and says it is still more fitting to honor such people, and speaks of the three kinds of shrines and the verses. The golden shrine hangs in the air for seven days; a schism arises at that time; when it returns, a great stone shrine stands in its place. Read the full commentary story, or about the Ghaṭīkāra Sutta.



North of Vegreville, Alberta

East-central Alberta, 1918

Ukrainian settlement in western Canada began in 1891 and 1892 at the Edna–Star colony east of Edmonton; by the First World War more than 100,000 Ukrainians and other eastern Europeans, most of the Ukrainians from Galicia and Bukovyna, had settled a band of parkland from Manitoba to Alberta, building whitewashed plastered houses and onion-domed churches, and marking graves with wooden crosses that were later replaced in iron and concrete (Canadian Encyclopedia; Canada's History). Priests were scarce, and lay cantors led much of the singing and reading. Because most had been Austro-Hungarian subjects, during the war some 80,000 Ukrainians and others were registered as "enemy aliens" and made to report regularly to the police, and about 8,600 were interned in camps (Ukrainian Canadian internment).

Settlers from Galicia were mostly Greek Catholic, those from Bukovyna mostly Orthodox, and disputes over clergy, bishops and church property ran through the colonies. In July 1918 disaffected Greek Catholic laymen from the three prairie provinces met in Saskatoon and formed a brotherhood to organize a Ukrainian Greek Orthodox Church; its first sobor followed that December (Ukrainian Orthodox Church of Canada; Western Development Museum). The potter Hnat's green-and-yellow ware belongs to the Hutsul tradition of Kosiv and Pistyn in the Carpathians. The dyak quotes the chapter "Concerning the honour due to the Saints and their remains" from John of Damascus's eighth-century *Exposition of the Orthodox Faith*. Pruth and Cheremosh districts and the Danylchuk chapel are invented.

After the story of the golden shrine of the Buddha Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 195–196). The original. Scripture from John of Damascus, *Exposition of the Orthodox Faith*, tr. S. D. F. Salmond, in the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (1899). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 15

Happiness

15.1

Bean Bread

Is not the life more than meat, and the body than raiment?
— Matthew 6:25

This is what the old people told, on Sycamore Branch.

I. Low Water

Sycamore Branch, Cherokee Nation · July 1846

In a wet year you could hear Sycamore Branch from the Deerinwater place, a mile below the mill, going over its stones all night like an old man telling himself a long story. By the time the corn was in tassel that summer it had stopped talking. What was left of it lay in green pools along the bed, one below another, with the minnows crowded so thick in them that a child could scoop them out with a gourd, and every morning a few more pools had gone to cracked mud and the smell of fish.

Above the pools stood Absalom Ware's dam.

He had built it four years before at the narrows, of oak logs and rock and brush packed with clay, and behind it the branch backed up into a long brown pond where his tub mill sat under a shake roof. People brought corn to that mill from twelve miles off, on horses and in sacks over their shoulders, and Ware took his toll, one gallon in eight, and sold the meal at Tahlequah along with the peaches from his orchard and the cotton his people picked. He was a careful man. When the dry weather came in June he shut the gate in the dam and kept it shut, and ground only on Saturdays, so the pond would hold a head of water through August. Below the dam the branch went on dying a pool at a time, and he did not go down to look at it.

Thomas Deerinwater went down every morning. He was a big quiet man who wore a hunting shirt and a dark blue turban wound around his head, as men of his age did, and spoke no English and wanted none. He could read and write his own language in Sequoyah's letters, and so could his wife and both his sons. His hogs wallowed in the last pools. His wife Sally carried water for the beans and squash from a spring that was going too, a little less every day, until the bucket came up half sand.

Sally Deerinwater and Lucy Ware were sisters. They were Wolf clan, both of them, from the same mother, and the way the Cherokee counted it that made their children Wolf as well, so that Lucy's boy at the mill and Sally's two big sons downstream were not cousins but brothers in the clan. They had not sat at the same fire in seven years.

There was a reason for that, and everybody in the Nation had one like it. Absalom Ware's cousin had put his name to the treaty paper at New Echota in the winter of 1835, the paper that sold the old country in Georgia and Tennessee for five million dollars. The cousin and the Ware family had come west in 1837 in wagons, ahead of the soldiers, with their bedsteads and their people. The rest of the Nation, the great part that never agreed to the paper, had been driven west the next year by the army. They went in the fall and the winter, a thousand to a party, mostly on foot. Four thousand of them were buried on the way. Lucy and Sally's mother was buried on the way, in Kentucky, in December, on the bank of the Ohio, while her party waited under a rock bluff for the ferryman to finish with his other customers. Sally had been there. Lucy had been in a log house on Sycamore Branch for a year by then, with a cookstove.

Then in June of 1839 men had gone out at dawn and killed three of the treaty signers in one day, and after that the killing did not stop. It went back and forth for seven years. That past November thirty-two armed men had ridden up to a treaty man's house and killed him and his grown son. In the spring there were more. By the summer of 1846 there were treaty families living over the line in Arkansas who would not come back, and there were men on both sides who did not sleep two nights in the same bed, and when two Cherokee met on a road they each looked first at the other's hands.

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On a Tuesday morning in the third week of July, John and Walter Deerinwater walked up the dry bed of the branch with two neighbor boys, carrying axes and a grubbing hoe, to open the gate in Ware's dam.

Ned and Sam were at the dam already, clearing leaves out of the millrace. They belonged to Absalom Ware. Ned was forty, a broad, slow, careful man who had been born in the old country on the Hiwassee and spoke Cherokee better than his master spoke English. Sam was younger and quicker and had a mouth on him.

Master says it stays shut till Saturday, Ned said.

The branch isn't his, said John Deerinwater. *It runs through my father's place same as his. Our hogs are dying.*

Then go tell him so. He's your kin. I can't open it, and you know I can't.

It might have ended there. Ned was a reasonable man and John Deerinwater was a reasonable man and both of them knew what the other one could and could not do. But Sam laughed and said that the Deerinwaters could water their hogs in the Illinois River like everybody else, it was only two miles, and Walter, who was seventeen, said that he would not take any talk from a man who belonged to a family that sold its own mothers' graves.

That was where it went over.

Sam said the Wares had never sold anything; it was the chief's own people who had got rich, his kinsmen with the contract for the removal, feeding the people on the road on spoiled beef at a fat price a head, everybody knew it. Walter said that a man who rode west in a wagon eating bacon while other people's grandmothers froze in Illinois had better not talk about beef. Sam said the Ross men were white men in turbans, half of them, and the other half were bean-bread Indians who could not write their own names. Walter said he could write his name in Sequoyah's letters, which was more than the Wares could, who had to get a white man to read them their own paper. One of the neighbor boys said something about Lucy Ware that should not have been said by anybody, and Sam swung the shovel.

Walter caught it on the axe handle. He swung back. Ned stepped in between them with both hands up, the way you step between two dogs, and the axe handle came down across his left forearm, and everybody on the dam heard the bone go.

Then they all stood still. Ned sat down on the logs and held his arm against his stomach and did not make a sound. John Deerinwater took the axe out of his brother's hands. Nobody opened the gate.

They went home, the four boys down the dry branch and Sam up the hill to the mill house with Ned walking behind him, and on the way each of them began to tell it.

II. The Rifles

Both sides of the branch · the same day and night

By noon, at the mill house, the Deerinwater boys had come up the branch with axes to tear out the dam and had broken Ned's arm when he tried to stop them, and had said in front of witnesses that the Wares would go the way the Starrs had gone. By noon at the Deerinwater place, Absalom Ware had set his black men on Thomas Deerinwater's sons with shovels, and Sam had said that the Ross people should go and drink out of the river with the hogs, and that was what treaty men thought of the Nation.

By evening it was older than that. It was New Echota and the wagons and the five million dollars. It was the beef contract. It was June of 1839 and who had ridden out at dawn that day and who had held the knives. It was everybody's dead.

Two years before, a quarrel over a mill dam would have gone to the district judge. In the summer of 1846 nobody in the Cherokee Nation trusted a judge who belonged to the other party. Absalom Ware sent his boy David, who was fifteen and had learned English at the mission school, riding east before dark to cousins who had gone over the line into Arkansas the winter before. Thomas Deerinwater sat in front of his cabin in the evening, smoking, and said nothing, and after dark the neighbors

began to come in from Flint District on horseback, one and two at a time, with their rifles across their saddles.

Lucy Ware set Ned's arm herself, at the kitchen table, with Ned's wife Hannah holding the lamp and Ned holding the edge of the table. She splinted it with two shingles and strips of a petticoat. When it was done Ned thanked her in Cherokee, and she said, also in Cherokee, *It was my sister's boy that did this,* and he said, *Yes, ma'am, it was,* and she went out on the porch and looked a long time down the dark branch to where there was a light.

Down at that light Sally Deerinwater was putting cold mud on her son Walter's hand, where the shovel had skinned the knuckles, and Walter was telling it again, and she said, *That is my sister's house you are talking about,* and Walter said, *She left you on the road,* and Sally slapped him, the first time since he was small, and then sat down on the floor and could not get up for a while.

In the morning there were eleven men with rifles at the Deerinwater place and nine at the mill, counting the Arkansas cousins, who had ridden all night. Ware did not ask Ned or Sam to carry a gun. He made Sam load for him.

They met at the dam an hour after sunrise. The Deerinwater side came up the dry bed of the branch and spread out along the east bank among the sycamores, and the Ware side came down from the mill and spread along the west bank behind the pond, and between them was the dam, and the shut gate, and the brown water with the sky in it, and about forty yards of air.

III. The Preacher

The Illinois River, below Tahlequah · before daylight

Old Bark had a cabin on a bluff over the Illinois River, sixteen miles from Sycamore Branch by the road, and he got up in the dark every morning of his life and went down to the river to pray.

He was the brother of Lucy and Sally's mother. Among the Cherokee that made him something more than an uncle: the mother's brother was

the one who taught the children, and corrected them, and spoke for them; a father belonged to another clan. He was past seventy. Evan Jones the Welshman had baptized him in the Valley River in the old country, in the cold, in front of the whole town, and for twenty years he had preached in Cherokee in brush arbors and log meeting houses, though he could not read a word of English. He carried the Gospel of Matthew in Sequoyah's letters, a small brown book that Samuel Worcester and Elias Boudinot had made between them and printed at New Echota in 1829. He had come west in the winter of 1838 with the Baptist detachment, Jesse Bushyhead's, and buried his sister in Kentucky and his wife in Missouri, and preached at both graves out of that book. One of the two men who had put it into Cherokee was among the three killed in June of 1839, a treaty signer. Old Bark had heard of it at a camp meeting and stopped his sermon and stood a long time with the book shut on his thumb, and then opened it and finished.

The old people said that when Bark prayed in the mornings he went over the whole Nation in his mind, the way a man walks his fence rows at first light to see where the stock has broken through. Every creek and every cabin. Who was sick, who was hungry, who was about to do something that could not be taken back. Nobody ever heard him claim this. It was only what people said.

That morning, on his knees on the gravel by the river, he saw Sycamore Branch. He saw the dam and the brown pond and the dry bed below it. He saw his sister's two daughters, one on each side, and their husbands, and twenty men with rifles, Wolf clan and Paint and Deer and Bird, some of whom he had put under the water himself, and he saw what they were going to do to each other in about an hour, when the sun was up.

He got up off his knees and went. He did not saddle his mare.

A boy fishing at the ford on the Tahlequah road saw him go by in the grey light, walking, an old man with a stick. A woman milking at Park Hill saw him pass, walking, and said afterward that he did not seem to be in any hurry. That was the last anybody saw of him on the road. Sixteen

miles. The sun was not a hand above the trees when he came to Sycamore Branch.

IV. Above the Water

Ware's dam · an hour after sunrise

NOBODY ON EITHER BANK SAW HIM COME. THAT WAS THE FIRST thing all of them agreed on, afterward, when they would agree on anything.

The men on the east bank had their rifles up. The men on the west bank had theirs up. Absalom Ware had just said something across the water in English, which the Deerinwater side did not understand and did not need to, and Thomas Deerinwater had lifted his hand to give the word, and then he did not give it, because there was an old man sitting in the air above the pond.

He was out over the water in front of the dam, about the height of a man's head, sitting the way an old man sits on a split-bottom chair in front of his own door, with his knees apart and his hands folded on top of his stick. He had on his black preaching coat and an old grey turban. His moccasins hung a few feet above the brown water, and the water under them reflected him, coat and stick and turban, the way it reflected the sycamores.

That was how the Deerinwater side told it. On the mill side some said he had been sitting on the top log of the dam all along and they had simply not seen him. Ned, who was standing behind his master with his arm in a sling, said that he had been looking straight at that spot, and there was nothing there, and then there was the old man, a little above the water, as easy as a bird on a limb, and that was all he had to say about it. Ned said it the same way the rest of his life, to anyone who asked, and he was not a man who embroidered.

The rifles came down. Nobody told them to. A man on the east bank, a Baptist, took off his turban. Two of the Arkansas cousins, who were Methodists and had never seen Bark before, stood with their mouths open. Lucy Ware, who had come down behind the men with her shawl

over her head, sat down on the bank. Across the water her sister had done the same.

Old Bark looked at the men on the west bank and the men on the east bank for a while. Then he spoke to his nephews-in-law, in Cherokee, the way he would have spoken across a supper table.

Absalom. What is this about?

Ware said it was about the Deerinwaters coming onto his land with axes.

Why did they come with axes?

Ware did not know exactly. Ask his cousins. The cousins from Arkansas said it was about the Ross men killing the Starrs, and before that the Ridges, and they had come to see that it did not happen again on Sycamore Branch. Bark turned on the air and asked Thomas Deerinwater, and Deerinwater said that it was about the treaty, and the road, and the people in the ground. Bark asked Deerinwater's neighbors from Flint, and they said it was about the Ware slaves being set on Cherokee boys with shovels. He asked John Deerinwater, who said it was about the hogs. He asked Walter, who said it was about something that had been said about his aunt.

Then he turned to the west bank again, and past Absalom Ware, and past the cousins, and looked at the man with his arm in the sling.

Ned. You were there. What is it about?

Ned looked at his master. Ware did not look back at him. Then Ned looked at the old man in the air and said it in Cherokee, so that both banks heard it.

Water, sir. It is about the water.

Old Bark nodded. He looked down past his moccasins at the pond, as if he had not noticed it before.

Absalom. How much is this water worth? If you sold it.

Ware said, after a while, that you could not sell creek water. It was worth nothing. There was a river two miles off.

Thomas. How much is a Cherokee man worth? If you sold him.

Thomas Deerinwater did not answer. Behind Ware, Ned shifted his arm in the sling and looked at the ground. The old man saw that and let

it stand, and nobody on either bank said anything for a while, because everybody knew there were men on Sycamore Branch who were bought and sold, and it was not the Cherokee.

We were sixteen thousand in the old country, Bark said. *We left four thousand on the road. I buried my sister on it, your mother, Lucy, and Sally, your mother. I buried my wife. Since we came here we have been burying each other. And this morning you came out to make the road longer, over something that is worth nothing, that you could not sell if you tried.*

If I had stayed on my knees by the river this morning, this branch would be running again by noon, and not with water.

Then he said: *It is not right.*

He did not say it loudly. Across the pond Sally Deerinwater put her face down on her knees.

V. Let Us Live

The same morning

THE OLD MAN CAME DOWN OUT OF THE AIR THEN. SOME SAID he stepped down onto the top log of the dam as if off the last rung of a ladder. Some said he was simply standing there. He leaned on his stick and took the brown book out of his coat and opened it to a place he did not need to look for, and read it out to them in Cherokee, slowly, one word at a time, the way people read Sequoyah's letters who learned them as grown men.

David Ware, who had ridden all night to fetch the Arkansas cousins and was standing at the end of the line with an empty shotgun, found the same verses years later in his schoolbook Bible in English. He wrote them down on the flyleaf with the date and the name of the branch. In English they were these:

> *But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you; That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.*
>
> *— Matthew 5:44–45*

He shut the book on his thumb.

There are men in this Nation who hate me, he said. *Because I am a Ross man, and because I am a Baptist, and because I preached at a treaty family's burying when nobody else from our side would go. Let them. I am going to live among them without hating them. I am too old to carry it.*

We all came over the road sick. Measles. The whooping cough. The flux. I have it in me yet, some mornings, in my chest. But the worst sickness we brought over the road is this one, and he put his stick out over the pond toward one bank and then the other. *The road is in you. Seven years and you are still on it. Every one of you. I am not going to be on it anymore. Let them be sick if they want. I am going to be well among them.*

Then he opened the book again, a little further on.

> *Therefore I say unto you, Take no thought for your life, what ye shall eat, or what ye shall drink; nor yet for your body, what ye shall put on. Is not the life more than meat, and the body than raiment?*
>
> *— Matthew 6:25*

Absalom wants the water because he wants the toll. Thomas wants it because Absalom has it. The Arkansas men want something they can never have back. Everybody in this Nation wants something, and I want something too, I am not a liar. But I am going to live among wanting people this way, without it. Look at me. I have a cabin and a mare and this book. I came sixteen miles this morning without breakfast. I am happy.

It was the most anyone had ever heard him say at one time, and after it he sat down on the dam with his legs over the side, like a boy, and was quiet.

• • •

Nobody gave an order. The men on the east bank leaned their rifles against the sycamores. On the west bank Absalom Ware handed his rifle to Sam, and then, after a moment, took it back and unloaded it himself and gave it to him again.

Then Ware walked out onto the dam, which he had built, and stood by the gate, and looked across the brown water at his wife's sister's husband. It was forty yards. It took Thomas Deerinwater a long time to come out and meet him on the logs, and when he did they did not shake hands, because they were not men who shook hands. They stood side by side and looked down at the gate.

If I pull it, said Ware in Cherokee, *I lose my head of water and the mill doesn't grind in August.*

Then don't pull it, said Deerinwater. *Cut it down a foot. Let some go over.*

So that is what they did. John Deerinwater and Sam worked the crosscut saw, one on each end, and Ned stood over them with his good hand on his hip and told them where, because it was Ned who had laid those logs four years before and knew where the top one was pinned. When the notch was cut the pond came to it and stood there trembling at the lip for a moment, as if deciding, and then it went over, a smooth brown tongue of water the width of a man's shoulders, and dropped into the dry bed below and began to run.

Old Bark watched it go.

Then he went over to John Deerinwater and said something to him that nobody else heard, and John walked up the bank to where Ned was standing and said, in Cherokee, in front of everybody, that he was sorry about the arm. It was not a small thing for a Cherokee man to say to an enslaved man in front of twenty people in that year, and everyone knew it. Absalom Ware opened his mouth and shut it again. Ned looked at John Deerinwater a while and said, *It'll mend,* which was true and was not the same thing as yes.

He had his own opinions about whose water it was, and about a great many other things. He kept them. He was the only one at the dam that

morning who had not been asked what he wanted. Four years before, a party of people held like himself had broken out near Webbers Falls and gone south for Mexico, where there were no slaves, and more than a hundred armed Cherokee and Choctaw men had gone after them and brought them back, and the council had passed harder laws. Ned stood on the bank and watched the water go over the notch toward the Deerinwater place, toward the Illinois, the Arkansas, the Mississippi, the Gulf, all the way down, and nobody at the dam asked him what he was thinking about, and he did not tell them.

VI. Bean Bread

The Deerinwater place · September 1846

In August word came from Washington that the parties had signed a treaty there, all of them together, with the government. All party distinctions were to cease. Every man in the Nation was pardoned for what he had done to any other. The armed police were done away with, and the light horse, and from now on no Cherokee would be punished for anything except by a jury. People read it to each other in English and in Cherokee, and some cried, and some spat, and the killing slowed down that fall, and then it mostly stopped.

On Sycamore Branch it had stopped already. The people who were at the dam that morning said, all the rest of their lives, that something had happened to them there that the treaty had nothing to do with. They did not agree on what it was, any more than they agreed on where exactly the old man had been sitting. Some of the Flint men went to the meeting house that fall and were baptized in the Illinois. One of the Arkansas cousins was baptized too, though he was a Methodist, and had to answer for it at home. Most of them never went near a church, and still could not afterward call a man from the other party a dog. They tried it, some of them, and found that it had gone out of them, the way a fever goes.

The rains came back the third week of August. The branch filled up and went over the notch and over the top of the whole dam besides, and

talked all night again, so that you could hear it from the Deerinwater place.

In September, when the beans were dry, Lucy Ware walked down the branch with a sack of meal on her hip from her husband's mill, with the toll not taken out of it, and knocked at her sister's door.

They did not say much. They sat on the floor by the fire the way their mother had sat, with the big kettle between them, and made bean bread the way their mother had made it: the meal and the boiled beans worked together with the bean water, hot enough to scald the hands, and patted into loaves, and each loaf wrapped in a green corn blade and tied with a strip of the blade, and dropped into the boiling kettle. Their mother's hands had been in all of it, the folding and the tying, and so their hands were. Lucy's knots were the same as Sally's knots. They had not been together in seven years, and the knots were the same.

They did not talk about the road. Sally talked about Walter, who was courting a Paint girl over toward Park Hill. Lucy talked about David, who wanted to go off to school in the States. They talked about Uncle Bark's chest, which was worse, and whether he would last the winter.

He did not. He died in February, in the cabin on the bluff, and they buried him on the bluff above the Illinois with the brown book in his coat. Both families stood at the grave, and Ned stood at the back with his hat in his good hand, and the other one, the one that had mended a little crooked, at his side.

But that was later. That afternoon in September the bean bread boiled in the kettle, twelve green bundles turning over and over each other in the rolling water, and the two sisters sat on either side of the fire with their hands in their laps, red to the wrist from the heat, and watched them.

Background

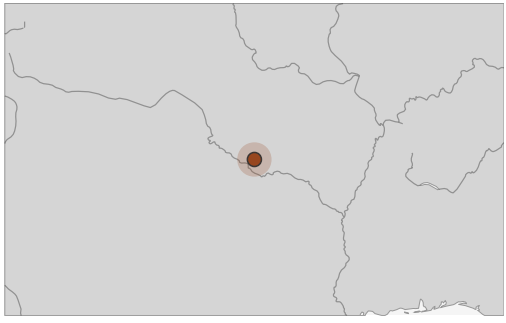
The verses

> *Let us live happily then, not hating those who hate us! among men who hate us let us dwell free from hatred!*
>
> Dhammapada 197, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Let us live happily then, free from ailments among the ailing! among men who are ailing let us dwell free from ailments!*
>
> Dhammapada 198, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Let us live happily then, free from greed among the greedy! among men who are greedy let us dwell free from greed!*
>
> Dhammapada 199, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Sākiyans and the Koliyans, two clans joined by generations of marriage, share a dam on the Rohiṇī River. In a dry summer their field hands quarrel over the water, trade insults about the founding of each other's royal houses, and carry the quarrel home, until both peoples march out armed to the river. The Buddha, kin to both, sees it at dawn, travels through the air, and sits above the river. The warriors lay down their weapons. He asks the nobles what the fight is about and gets no answer, and works down the ranks to the laborers, who say it is about water. He asks what water is worth and what the lives of warriors are worth, and tells them it is not right to destroy what is priceless for what is worth almost nothing. He ends with the three verses, each beginning *let us live happily*. Read the full commentary story.



Cherokee Nation, Indian Territory

The Cherokee Nation, 1839–1846

In December 1835 a small faction of Cherokee leaders, the Treaty Party, signed the Treaty of New Echota, giving up the Nation's lands in the Southeast for land in the West and five million dollars. The elected government under John Ross never accepted it. Many treaty families moved west in 1837; the rest of the Nation was rounded up by the army in 1838 and marched west in detachments of about a thousand through an unusually cold winter. About 4,000 died on the Trail of Tears. One detachment was led by the Baptist minister Jesse Bushyhead, and another by the Welsh missionary Evan Jones, who had learned Cherokee and who re-founded the Baptist Mission in the new country. In June 1839 Major Ridge, John Ridge and Elias Boudinot, three treaty signers, were killed on the same day. Boudinot had worked with the missionary Samuel Worcester on the Cherokee Gospel of Matthew, printed at New Echota in 1829 in Sequoyah's syllabary.

Killings and revenge killings between the parties went on for seven years. In November 1845 armed men killed the treaty man James Starr and his son Buck at their home, and at least 34 political killings are counted in 1845 and 1846 (see Tom Starr). On August 6, 1846, the parties signed a treaty at Washington declaring that "all party distinctions shall cease," pardoning past offenses, abolishing the armed police and light horse, and promising trial by jury. Wealthier Cherokee, many of them treaty men, held Black people in slavery; in November 1842 about twenty enslaved people escaped near Webbers Falls and fled toward Mexico before a force of Cherokee and Choctaw men caught them near the Red River. Afterward the Nation passed harsher slave codes (see the 1842 slave revolt). Sycamore Branch, the Saunders and Deerinwater families and Old Bark are fictional.

After the story of the Sākiyans and Koliyans from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 197–199). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

15.2

Crowns on Their Heads

> *The righteous sit enthroned, their crowns on their heads, and enjoy the lustre of the Shekinah.*
> *— Talmud, Berakot 17a*

Azoy hob ikh gehert, on the Hill.

I. The Suits

Los Alamos, New Mexico · September 1950

Morris Halpern had come out to the Hill from Bayonne in the spring of 1945 with a toolbox, a wife, and a five-year-old daughter who was sick on every curve of the road up from the river. He ran a lathe. He had run one at the Standard Oil works on Constable Hook and he ran one on the mesa, in a shop behind a fence, making parts he was not told the use of and did not ask about. When the war ended the people who had come for the war began to leave, and the Halperns did not. There was work. There was a house in the Western Area with a yard of pine needles and a view of the Jemez, and a school, and the gate.

Everybody on the Hill knew the gate. You showed your pass to the guard at the guardhouse on the road in, and if your mother was coming from Bayonne for Passover you went down in person and signed for her a day ahead, and the guard looked at her face and then at the paper and then at her face. Nobody locked a door. Children left their bicycles lying in the street all night. The fence kept everything out, people said, and in the evening the floodlights came on along the fence by the pond and lay out across the water, white, so that the ducks slept in light.

That summer the newspapers came up the hill full of names. A man in England in February. A chemist in Philadelphia in May. In June a ma-

chinist from New York who had worked on the Hill during the war, in the shops, and then a man named Rosenberg, his brother-in-law, and then in August the wife. Morris read every word at the kitchen table and folded the paper small and did not say anything. He had not known the machinist from New York. Thousands of people had passed through the Hill in those years. He said so once, to the wall, and then not again.

The two men in gray suits came on a Thursday in September, in the afternoon, and sat in the front room with their hats on their knees while Esther did her arithmetic in the kitchen and listened. They were polite. They asked about 1945. They asked about a union meeting in Bayonne in 1937, and about Morris's brother Hymie, who sold the *Freiheit* on Broadway in Bayonne and always had. They asked who had come to the Seder. When they left they shook hands with her father and with her mother and nodded to Esther through the doorway.

On Monday Morris Halpern's clearance was suspended pending a hearing, and he came home at ten in the morning with his toolbox.

After that the street went quiet around them the way snow goes quiet. Nobody was unkind. Mrs. Dorsey in the steel house on Fairway Drive still said good morning, and then went in. The women who had stood in the Halperns' kitchen every Saturday drinking coffee stood in other kitchens. At school the teacher moved Esther's desk, for the light, she said. Esther was ten. She wrote to her grandfather in Bayonne every Sunday, and her grandfather, who had pressed pants for forty years and studied a page of Gemara every night of them, wrote back in Yiddish in a hand like barbed wire, and her mother read it to her, and at the bottom of every letter he wrote, in English, for her, *Be happy, Essie, it costs nothing.*

II. The Doors

Tuesday, October 31

Her mother bought her a mask at the commissary, a black cat on a string, and washed a pillowcase that morning and ironed it flat on the board with the sprinkle bottle, the way she ironed everything,

SO THAT IT WAS FOLDED IN A SQUARE ON THE KITCHEN TABLE when Esther came home from school, smelling of the iron.

You don't have to go, her mother said.

It's Halloween.

She put the mask in her coat pocket and did not put it on. Her mother saw that and said nothing. Her father was sitting in the front room with a lamp on in the daytime and a lathe catalogue open on his knee. He got up and walked her to the door and stood in it.

Who are you supposed to be? he said.

Me.

It was dark by six and cold, with the smell of piñon smoke coming down from the stovepipes of the older houses. Up and down the Western Area the porch lights were on, every one, and the children were out in packs, cowboys and skeletons and hoboes with burnt-cork beards, and more Hopalong Cassidys than anyone could count, because that was the year of Hopalong Cassidy, and the commissary had sold out of the black hats by the twentieth.

The Dorseys' porch light went out when Esther was halfway up the walk. She stood on the step a while in the dark and then she knocked anyway, and nobody came.

At the Kittredges' the door opened and Mr. Kittredge stood in it with a mixing bowl of Tootsie Rolls held against his stomach and looked down at her face, the bare face, and said, *We're all out, honey,* and shut the door.

At the Lindgrens' Mrs. Lindgren had made popcorn balls in waxed paper, and said, *Oh,* and looked over her shoulder into the house, and said, *Oh, Esther, I'm sorry,* and closed the door slowly, as though that were kinder.

She went up one side of the street and down the other. It was the strangest thing anybody had seen on the Hill, people said afterward, stranger than anything that came out of the Tech Area, and nobody could account for it. Doors that opened for every Hopalong on the street did not open for her. Hands that were full went empty when she came up the walk. One man who did not know her from Adam, a visitor from Albuquerque signed in for the week, stood in the doorway of the guest

apartment holding a whole carton of Bit-O-Honey and could not, he said later, for the life of him lift his arm.

And the children in masks found her. They came round her at the corner of Forty-Fourth Street, eight or nine of them, rubber faces, a Frankenstein, a skull, three Hopalongs, and they did not touch her. They clapped. They clapped in her face, close, and laughed behind the rubber, and one of them said it, and then all of them said it, in time with the clapping, the word everybody's father said at the dinner table that year, and Esther stood still until they were finished and walked on. In the morning, every one of those children swore they had not been out on that corner at all. They had been at home. They had been at the party. Their mothers backed them up.

The pillowcase was as clean as when her mother folded it. It had the creases in it still.

III. The Fence

Ashley Pond · the same night

The road home went past the pond, where the floodlights were on along the fence on the far side, and at the corner where the fence came down to the road there was a man.

He was leaning on the post by the little gate there, the one the guards used, in a good camel-hair coat with the collar up, and he had a red devil's mask on, the kind with the horns molded in, and he was smoking a cigarette under the chin of it. He was not a guard. The guard was in his booth a hundred yards off with the radio on. Afterward nobody on the Hill could say who the man had been. The commissary had not sold a red mask that year, only the cats and the skulls. Nobody's husband owned a camel-hair coat.

Hiya, Essie, he said. *Nothing, huh?*

She stopped. She looked at the mask a long time.

Why'd you do that? she said.

He laughed. He had a nice laugh, a radio laugh.

Go around again, he said. *Go on. Go around the whole Western Area one more time. Maybe they'll have come around.* He tipped his ash. He was thinking, Esther understood, about the clapping, and about how much more of it there could be the second time, and the porch lights going out one after another down the street like a row of teeth, and he wanted to see it.

Then the girls came down the hill from the school.

There had been a party in the gym for the Brownies and the Girl Scouts, with a witch's cauldron of cider and a washtub for apples, and they came down the road together still laughing, eleven or twelve of them, Margie Ostrom and Patsy Delgado and Kay Lindgren and the Sheffield twins and the rest. Their hair was wet to the shoulders from bobbing, and every one of them was a Cinderella. That was the other thing that year. The picture had come up from Santa Fe in the spring and played at the Hill theater for two weeks, and their mothers had sat up nights making blue gowns out of old taffeta and pillowcase muslin, and the dime store in Santa Fe had been cleaned out of the rhinestone crowns, which came on a little comb and cost fifteen cents, so that a whole troop of wet-headed girls came down the road in the floodlight with crowns in their hair, and the crowns caught the light coming across the water and threw it back.

They saw Esther and they stopped. Some of them had not spoken to her since September. Their mothers had said not to.

Hi, Essie, said Patsy Delgado.

Hi, Essie, said Kay Lindgren, whose mother had closed the door slowly.

And the rest of them said it, and stood around her on the side of the road with their pillowcases, which were full, and their crowns, which were crooked, and did not know why they had stopped.

The man at the gate pushed himself off the post.

Kid hasn't got a single Tootsie Roll, he said to the girls. *Not one. Look in her bag.* And to Esther, softly, as if he were sorry for her: *You must be starving.*

Esther looked at the girls, at the wet hair and the crowns. She thought of her grandfather on Avenue C in Bayonne, at the table under the light

with the big book open, and of the thing he said at every meal when somebody pushed back from the table complaining they were full, or complaining they were hungry, which in her grandfather's house came to the same thing. He said it in Yiddish and then he said it again in English, for her, the way Rav said it in the old book, and it was the only piece of the Gemara she knew by heart.

My zeyde says, she said to the man in the devil's face, *that's not how it works.*

> *Not like this world is the world to come. In the world to come there is neither eating nor drinking; no procreation of children or business transactions; no envy or hatred or rivalry; but the righteous sit enthroned, their crowns on their heads, and enjoy the lustre of the Shekinah.*
>
> *— Talmud, Berakot 17a*

Then she sat down on the low stone wall along the pond, with her empty pillowcase in her lap, in the light.

The girls looked at each other. Then Patsy Delgado sat down beside her, and Margie Ostrom on the other side, and the Sheffield twins, and the rest of them all along the wall in their blue gowns, and nobody opened a candy bar. The floodlights came across the water in long white bars and lay on them. Their crowns went on and off as they moved their heads. Somebody laughed, and then somebody else did, at nothing, at the cold, at Kay Lindgren's crown that had slid down over one ear, and then all of them were laughing, twelve girls and Esther on a wall in the light with their wet hair steaming, and none of them could have said what was so funny, and none of them could stop.

When they looked up the man was gone. The guard in the booth, asked about it the next day by more people than he could remember, said he had seen nobody at the little gate all night. He had seen the girls on the wall. He had heard them laughing from his booth, over the radio, he said, and he had turned the radio down to listen to it, because it was the best thing he had heard in that place.

They sat until the cold came through the taffeta. Then they walked Esther home, all of them, up Forty-Fourth Street and past the Dorseys' and the Kittredges', where the porch lights were on again, and left her at her door.

IV. The Guardhouse

The road in · 1951 and after

The hearing was in January. Morris Halpern sat at a long table in a room in the administration building and answered the same questions as in September, and some new ones, for two days. In March they gave him his clearance back, and he went back to his lathe, and nobody on Fairway Drive ever said anything about it, then or later, which was how things were done on the Hill. Mrs. Dorsey brought over a coffee cake. Esther's desk was moved back, for the light.

As for the girls, the people who told the story afterward could never quite say what had happened to them, only that it had. They were not saints. They grew up and argued with their mothers and went to dances in Santa Fe. But it was noticed that not one of them, ever after, could be got to say the word the masked children had clapped. Not as a joke. Not when their fathers said it at dinner. And it was noticed that when somebody on the Hill was having a bad time, a husband let go or a boy in trouble with the police, those were the girls who turned up at the door. They did not bring anything. They sat on the step and talked, and laughed, and went home.

On the eighteenth of February, 1957, the Atomic Energy Commission took down the gates. People turned out on the road in the snow to watch the governor drive through without a pass, and Esther Halpern, sixteen, stood among them in her school coat beside Patsy Delgado and Kay Lindgren. Afterward the guardhouse stood empty, and in time somebody opened it up as a drive-in and sold hamburgers out of the window where the guards had looked at your mother's face.

She kept the pillowcase. Her mother put it back on Esther's own pillow the week after Halloween and it stayed there until it wore through,

and then her mother cut it into dust rags, and Esther, home from college, found the last square of it in the rag drawer under the sink and kept that. It was soft by then as a handkerchief, and it had never once, in all those years, had anything in it.

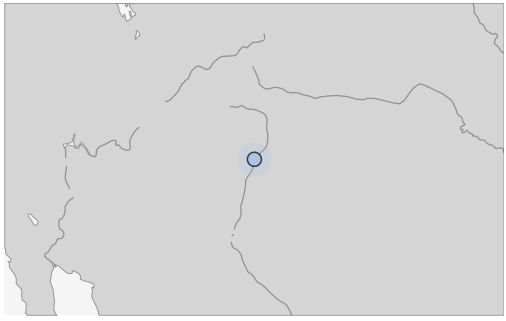
Background

The verse

> *Let us live happily then, though we call nothing our own! We shall be like the bright gods, feeding on happiness!*
>
> Dhammapada 200, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha sees that five hundred young women of the brahmin village of Pañcasālā are ready to understand, and goes there for alms on a festival day. Māra, the tempter, takes possession of every villager, and the Buddha leaves with his bowl as clean as when it was washed. Māra waits at the village gate, asks whether he got nothing, and urges him to go round again, meaning to have the villagers clap and jeer in his face. Just then the young women, fresh from bathing and dressed for the festival, arrive at the gate and greet him, and Māra remarks that he must be suffering from hunger. The Buddha answers that though he received nothing, he will pass the day in joy, like the gods of Streaming Light who feed on rapture, and the women enter the stream. Read the full commentary story.

Esther's grandfather's saying is from the tractate Berakhot of the Babylonian Talmud, a saying of Rav about the world to come, in A. Cohen's 1921 translation.



Los Alamos, New Mexico

Los Alamos, 1950

Los Alamos was built in secret on a mesa above the Rio Grande in 1943 for the Manhattan Project and stayed a fenced, guarded town for twelve years after the war. Under the Atomic Energy Commission, civilian guards replaced soldiers at the gates, outsiders came in only by invitation with a pass arranged in advance, and residents famously left their doors unlocked. The gates came down on February 18, 1957, when Governor Edwin Mechem drove through first without a pass, and the main guard station was later replaced for a time by a drive-in burger stand. The postwar Western Area included six experimental Lustron houses of porcelain-enameled steel, put up in 1949 on Fairway Drive and 44th Street.

The year 1950 brought the atomic spy cases home to the Hill. Klaus Fuchs, of the wartime British mission, was arrested in England in February; the courier Harry Gold confessed in May; David Greenglass, an Army machinist who had worked at Los Alamos from 1944 to 1946, was arraigned in June; and his brother-in-law Julius Rosenberg and sister Ethel were arrested in July and August (FBI history; the Rosenbergs). Clearances were reviewed across the weapons complex. It was also the year of Hopalong Cassidy, when more than a hundred companies made some $70 million worth of his merchandise. The Halperns, their street and their hearing are invented.

After the story of Māra from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 200). The original. Talmud from *Tractate Berakot*, tr. A. Cohen (Cambridge, 1921). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

15.3

The Level

For he who is placed on the lowest spoke of fortune's wheel, may be entitled to our regard.
— Webb, The Freemason's Monitor

As it was told at the forge, on Tonawanda Creek.

I. The Sister's Meadow

Genesee County, New York · 1826

Judge Amos Thurber had been Master of Concord Lodge in Kendrick's Mills four times and first judge of the county court once, and he had built the stone house at the head of the street with money he made selling lots along the creek when the canal came through. He was sixty-one. He wore his hair in a queue still, the old way, tied with a black ribbon, and in winter he walked to the lodge room over Fenn's tavern with a lantern, though it was forty rods and he knew every board of the sidewalk.

His sister Lucy had married a Pease and been given, as her portion, the island meadow in the bend below the mill, eleven acres of the best grass on the creek. When Pease died owing, the judge bought the meadow back at the sheriff's sale to keep it in the family, and he kept it. Lucy died the next winter. Her boy Lyman, who was fourteen then, went to live with the judge in the stone house, and was sent to the academy at Batavia, and read law in an office in Rochester, and came home at twenty-three with a long chin and a short temper and a way of looking at the island meadow out the judge's front window that the judge's wife noticed and did not mention.

That was the year a man named Morgan was taken out of the jail at Canandaigua in the night and carried off in a closed carriage toward Fort Niagara and never seen again. He had been writing a book to print the secrets of the lodge. Everybody in the county knew some piece of it: who had driven the carriage, who had held the horses, which brother's barn they had changed horses in. Men who had sat in lodge with Judge Thurber for twenty years went before the grand jury and would not say what they knew, and that, more than the carriage, was what the county could not forgive.

By the next spring there were meetings in every schoolhouse, resolving not to vote for any Mason for any office whatever. The churches took it up. The Baptists in Kendrick's Mills voted to withhold fellowship from any member who would not renounce the lodge, and the judge, who had given the land their meetinghouse stood on, did not renounce it, and sat at home on the Sabbath after that with a book.

Lyman Pease spoke at every one of the schoolhouse meetings. He was good at it. He had a way of lowering his voice at the end, so that people leaned in.

II. Three Town Meetings

Kendrick's Mills · April 1827, 1828, 1829

THE TOWN MEETING WAS HELD IN THE SPRING AT FENN'S, IN the long room downstairs, with the bar shut. The judge had been supervisor of the town for nine years running. In April of 1827 his nephew stood against him on the Anti-Masonic ticket, and the town voted with its hands up, and when they were counted Lyman Pease had won by thirty-one.

The judge shook his hand in front of everybody. That night he walked up to the lodge room with his lantern, and found the door locked and Zeb Crane the Tyler sitting outside it on the bench, as he always sat, with the old sword across his knees.

Nobody's come, said Zeb.

In 1828 the judge stood again, because his friends said the fever would pass and because he could not imagine not standing, and he lost by seventy. It was the spring after a body had come up on the Lake Ontario shore and the Anti-Masonic papers had said it was Morgan's. Two of the judge's lodge brothers took their names off the roll in a notice in the Batavia paper. Concord Lodge stopped meeting. In the stores men who owed the judge money crossed the street.

In 1829 he stood a third time, against all advice, and he made a speech, which he had never done in his life. He stood at the head of the long room in his black coat with his queue tied and said that he had held the deeds to half the town and the Bible for the other half, and that he had never cheated a man, and that he did not know what had been done to William Morgan and would have hanged the men who did it with his own hands. Then Lyman Pease got up and lowered his voice at the end, and the hands went up, and the judge lost by a hundred and four.

He walked home without his lantern. He went into the front room and looked out the window at the island meadow, which was just coming green, and said to his wife, *I could not beat a boy I bought shoes for. What is the use of me?* He went up to bed in the middle of the afternoon with his boots on, and he did not come down for supper.

He did not come down the next day either, or the next. His wife took up a tray, and brought it down again, and took it up again. He lay on his back with his eyes open and his queue untied on the pillow. On the fourth day the doctor came from Batavia and said there was nothing the matter with him that he could find, and that a man of his age could die of nothing in a week if he set his mind to it.

III. The Tyler

The forge below the mill · the same week

Zeb Crane had been Tyler of Concord Lodge since it was chartered. He was a blacksmith and a short, thick, silent man, and for thirty years his whole office had been to sit outside the door of the lodge room with a sword and keep it. He let in who was entitled and kept out

WHO WAS NOT, AND HE HAD NEVER ONCE IN THIRTY YEARS been inside while the lodge was at work. He heard it through the door: every degree, every lecture, every installation of officers, every charge. He knew the whole of it better than the Masters who said it, people said, because he had never had to think about anything else while he listened.

When the lodge stopped meeting he went on keeping the key. Some evenings he still went up and sat on the bench. Nobody knew why, and nobody asked him.

It was three of the old brothers who came down to the forge to tell him about the judge, Fenn the tavern keeper and two others, and stood in the door while he worked. They told it the way men tell a thing they are ashamed of: the judge would not eat, the judge would not get up, the judge had said *what is the use of me*. And it was that boy, Fenn said. Lucy's boy, who he had raised. He has gone round the county saying the Masons murdered a man and the Masons ought to be run out, and now he has run his own uncle into the bed. I hope he is satisfied. There are men in this town who would like to see him in the creek.

Zeb Crane finished the shoe he was drawing and set it on the anvil to cool, and wiped his hands, and said more than any of them had heard him say at one time.

He wins, and you want him in the creek. Amos loses, and he's lying in the bed with his boots on. That's all winning does, that I ever saw, and all losing does. He looked at the shoe. *You have got to get off of that.*

Then he went up the street to the stone house in his apron, and the judge's wife let him in, and he climbed the stairs and sat down on a straight chair at the foot of the judge's bed, the way he had sat on the bench outside the lodge door, with his hands on his knees.

The judge turned his head and looked at him a long time.

You've come to tell me to eat, he said.

No, said Zeb. *I've come to tell you something you said to me. You said it every year for thirty years and I don't believe you ever listened to it once, because you were the one saying it.* And he said it, slowly, in the flat voice of a man repeating what he has heard through a door, the charge the Master

gives the Senior Warden on the night he puts the jewel on him, which is a level, with a little plumb line hanging in it.

> *The Level demonstrates that we are descended from the same stock, partake of the same nature, and share the same hope; and though distinctions among men are necessary to preserve subordination, yet no eminence of station should make us forget that we are Brethren; for he who is placed on the lowest spoke of fortune's wheel, may be entitled to our regard; because a time will come, and the wisest knows not how soon, when all distinctions, but that of goodness, shall cease; and death, the grand leveler of human greatness, reduce us to the same state.*
>
> *— Thomas Smith Webb,*
>
> The Freemason's Monitor
> *, Charge to the Senior Warden*

The judge lay still.

The lowest spoke, he said finally.

It goes round, said Zeb. *That's what a wheel does. Lyman is on the top of it this spring. Somebody is going to have to sit with him too, when it comes round.* He got up. *A man that's not on it at all sleeps fine. I've slept fine for thirty years on a bench.*

That was all he said. He went down the stairs and back to the forge, and the shoe on the anvil was cool enough to handle, and he went on with his work.

IV. The Jewel

Kendrick's Mills · 1829 and after

THE JUDGE'S WIFE SAID AFTERWARD THAT HE LAY A LONG while after the Tyler had gone, looking at the ceiling, and then laughed once, not unhappily, and asked what there was to eat. There was bread and there was cold mutton. He ate it sitting on the edge of the bed with

HIS FEET BARE, AND ASKED FOR MORE BREAD, AND THEN HE tied his queue and went down.

Of the three brothers who had stood in the door of the forge, people said, none of them ever spoke again of putting anybody in the creek. Fenn opened the long room the next April for the town meeting the same as always, and set out water for both tickets, and voted, people said, for whoever he pleased and told nobody.

The judge did not stand again. He deeded the island meadow to Lyman Pease that summer, as Lucy's portion, with nothing asked, and Lyman did not know what to make of it, and was suspicious of it for years. When the Anti-Masonic party went to pieces in the middle of the thirties, and Lyman Pease was beaten for the assembly by a man nobody had heard of, and sat for a week in his office in Batavia with the blinds down, it was the old judge who drove over in the gig and sat with him. Nobody knows what he said. Something about a wheel, Lyman's wife thought.

Zeb Crane kept the key to the lodge room until he died. In the summers, when the forge was too hot, he did his whittling on the bench outside the locked door. Concord Lodge got a new charter in 1851 and met again over Fenn's, and the Senior Warden's jewel they hung on the new man the night of the installation was the old one, a little silver level with a plumb line hung inside it on a thread. The judge's widow had kept it in a drawer. When the Master set it on the young man's chest, the plumb swung, and the room was quiet while it swung, and then it settled on the mark.

Background

The verse

> *Victory breeds hatred, for the conquered is unhappy. He who has given up both victory and defeat, he, the contented, is happy.*
>
> Dhammapada 201, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi of Kosala fights his nephew Ajātasattu, king of Magadha, near the village of Kāsi and is beaten three times. (The quarrel was over that village, which had been given as a dowry to Pasenadi's sister, Ajātasattu's mother, and which Pasenadi took back after Ajātasattu killed his father.) Coming home from the third defeat, the old king says to himself, "Since I cannot beat this milk-faced boy, what is the use of my living?" and refuses food and takes to his bed. The monks tell the Buddha, who answers that the winner breeds hatred and the beaten man lies down in pain, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.

Zeb Crane's charge is the one given to the Senior Warden, whose jewel is the level, at the installation of a lodge's officers, as printed in Thomas Smith Webb's *Freemason's Monitor*, the standard American ritual handbook since 1797, quoted here from the 1867 Cincinnati edition. The Tyler is the officer who guards the lodge door with a sword and normally stays outside it.

Genesee County, New York

Western New York, 1826–1829

In September 1826 William Morgan of Batavia, who was preparing a book exposing Masonic ritual, was jailed at Canandaigua over a small debt, released at night into a waiting carriage, and taken to Fort Niagara, after which he vanished; he is generally believed to have been drowned in the Niagara River. A badly decomposed body that washed up on the Lake Ontario shore in October 1827 was claimed as his. The Niagara County sheriff, a Mason, was removed and served twenty-eight months for conspiracy, and several other men were convicted, but the reward for information was never claimed, and the sense that Masons were shielding Masons turned grief into a movement.

In early 1827 mass meetings across western New York resolved not to vote for Masons for any office, and evangelical churches across the Burned-over District, Presbyterian, Congregational, Methodist and Baptist, condemned members and ministers who belonged to the order. Out of this came the Anti-Masonic Party, the first American third party, which won fifteen seats in the New York Assembly that fall

and nominated William Wirt for president in 1832, then faded almost everywhere by 1835. Kendrick's Mills, Concord Lodge, and everyone in the story are invented.

After the story of the defeat of the King of Kosala from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 201). The original. The charge from Thomas Smith Webb, *The Freemason's Monitor* (Cincinnati edition, 1867). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

15.4

Strained Water

> *The fire is quenched when the fuel fails, but the desire ceases not.*
> *— St. John of the Cross, The Ascent of Mount Carmel*

So it was told in the kitchens, along the Port Tobacco River.

I. The Linen

Charles County, Maryland · June 1791

The spring below the Edelen house ran clear all winter and muddy every summer, after the June rains, and in the muddy months it was full of wigglers. Phillis, who cooked for the Edelens and had cooked for them since before the war with England, strained it for the table through a square of old linen tied over the mouth of the pitcher, and when Miss Monica was a little girl she stood at Phillis's elbow on a stool and watched the wigglers caught in the cloth, kicking, and asked every time whether they would live, and every time Phillis turned the linen out over the grass by the spring so that they could go back.

So when Monica Edelen was nineteen and was to be married, and the old priests were coming to the wedding, she would let nobody strain the water for them but herself. She said it was because they were holy men. Phillis thought it was because she liked to.

She was marrying Raphael Boarman, the second son from up the Wicomico, a tall, handsome, restless young man who had spent a winter at Annapolis studying law and come home having studied cards and dice instead, and owing a man named Dorsey sixty pounds, and hating him. He had looked at Monica at Mass at the manor at Easter and had not been able to look at anything else since. Her father said that was a fine

thing in a young man and would settle him. Phillis, who was in the kitchen yard the day he came to ask, and saw how he looked at the girl through the window, said nothing, because it was not hers to say.

The wedding was set for the Tuesday after Corpus Christi. The old Reverend Mr. Hagan would marry them. He had baptized Monica. He had baptized her father.

II. The Priest

St. Thomas Manor, on the Port Tobacco River

He was seventy-one. He had been born in St. Mary's County and sent over the sea as a boy, because no Catholic could keep a school in Maryland then, to the English Jesuit college at St. Omer in Flanders, and from there to Liège, and had come home a priest of the Society of Jesus and ridden the circuit of the Catholic houses for twenty years, saying Mass in parlors with the shutters closed. Then in 1773 the Pope put an end to the Society. The old priests of Maryland went on living exactly as before, in the same brick house on the bluff at St. Thomas, riding the same circuits, and only were not Jesuits any more. They had had a bishop since the summer before, the first one in the country, and Mr. Hagan said that was very well and went on riding.

He was a lean man with the gout in his left knee, and he spoke so little at table that visitors thought him slow. He had one book in his saddlebag that was not a breviary: a little Spanish book, worn soft, that he had bought from a Carmelite friar in Antwerp forty years before. He read it on horseback at a walk.

The summer before, four Carmelite nuns had come up the bay from Norfolk in a sloop, from their convent in Flanders, three of them Maryland women going home, and had taken a house and farm in the woods north of Port Tobacco. They were the first in the country. They kept the enclosure, and nobody saw their faces but through a grille, and Mr. Hagan rode over twice in the week to hear their confessions. People asked him what the nuns did all day. *They rest,* he said. People took that for one of his jokes.

One of the nuns was Monica Edelen's mother's cousin. Monica sent her a cheese.

III. The Pitcher

The Edelen house · the Tuesday after Corpus Christi

THEY WERE MARRIED IN THE PARLOR IN THE MORNING WITH the shutters open, which Monica's grandmother said she had not lived to see in that house until that day. Then the long tables were set out on the grass under the poplars, and the old gentlemen of the county sat down at them in their wigs, the Neales and the Brookes and the Digges and the Boarmans and the Hamersleys, and five old priests in black at the head, and a fiddler, a man named Jerry who belonged to the Brookes, played from a kitchen chair under the trees.

It was the bridegroom's part to see to the old men. To carry the chairs and pour the wine and stand behind his father-in-law's chair and hear old stories about the French war. Raphael Boarman did none of it. He stood in the parlor door with his arms crossed and watched his wife.

She went up and down the tables with the pitcher. She stopped beside each old priest and poured the spring water into his cup through her square of linen, slowly, and turned the linen out on the grass behind the chair, and went on to the next, in her wedding gown with her sleeves turned back. And Raphael Boarman watched her go, and come back, and go, and something got up in him that he had felt at the dice table in Annapolis at two in the morning, only worse, a heat that started in his chest and went down his arms into his hands, and he made up his mind. When she came past the door again he would take her in his arms, there, in front of all of them, the wigs and the priests and the fiddler and her grandmother. Let them look.

She came up the grass with the pitcher. Phillis saw it, from the kitchen door, and told it after for forty years, and was never once contradicted by anyone who had been there.

Monica walked up the grass toward her husband with the pitcher in both hands, and she passed within a yard of him, close enough to touch

his sleeve, and he did not see her. He looked straight through her at the poplars. She went by him into the house and came out again with the pitcher full, and passed him again, and he did not see her. Every soul at the tables saw her. The fiddler saw her. Her grandmother saw her. Raphael Boarman stood in the door with his arms half out from his sides, like a man feeling for a wall in the dark, and turned his head this way and that, and could not find his wife anywhere in the world.

He went white. He looked down the long tables for her, and what he found instead was the old priest at the head of them, looking back at him. Mr. Hagan had his cup in his hand and his bad leg out straight on a cushion, and he was the only person at the tables who was not looking at the bride.

Raphael went down the grass to him as if he were being pulled.

Where is she?

Sit down, Raphael.

He sat. The old man looked at him a long time, the way he looked at a horse before he bought it.

There is no fire like that one, he said. *You have seen a tobacco barn burn. That is nothing to it. A barn burns down, and then it is out.* He turned the cup in his hand. *And there is no throw at the dice so bad as hating a man. You lost sixty pounds to Dorsey. You have lost more than that to him since, every night you lie awake hating him, and you will go on losing it as long as you keep the dice in your hand. And there is no ache like this.* He touched his own knee, and then, lightly, the young man's hand. *This. All of it. The whole box we carry about. You will find that out.*

And there is no happiness like rest. He looked away north, toward the woods past Port Tobacco where the nuns were. *None. People laugh when I say so.*

Then he said that a Spanish friar had written it better than he could, two hundred years ago, and he said it in Spanish, slowly, and then said it again in English for the young man, looking for the words, the way he had been translating it to himself on horseback for forty years.

> *The desires are, as it is commonly said, like fire which burns when supplied with fuel, but which, when the fuel is consumed, immediately dies. In truth, the desire is in a much worse condition: the fire is quenched when the fuel fails, but the desire ceases not with the matter on which it fed while it raged, even though that be utterly consumed; for instead of ceasing, like fire when the fuel is burnt out, the desire pines away in weariness, for hunger is increased, and food diminished.*
>
> *— St. John of the Cross,*
> The Ascent of Mount Carmel
> *, I.6*

Raphael Boarman sat at the table with his hands flat on the cloth. Nobody near them spoke. The fiddler had stopped, though nobody had told him to. Whatever had got up in the young man in the doorway sat down again, Phillis said, the way a dog does when it hears its name, and he put his face in his hands, and when he took them away he was quiet all through, quiet as she had never seen a white man quiet who was not dead.

The old man nodded at something behind him.

Monica was standing at his shoulder with the pitcher and the linen. She had been standing there all along, and had heard every word of it, and her face, Phillis said, was as quiet as his. She poured her husband a cup of the spring water through the cloth, slowly, the way she poured it for the priests, and he looked at her as if he had never seen her before, and drank it.

IV. The Square of Linen

Charles County · afterward

They were married fifty-one years. Raphael Boarman never threw dice again, and paid Dorsey his sixty pounds in the fall, in person, at Annapolis, and shook his hand, and came home, and Dorsey told it at every tavern on the Severn as the strangest thing that had ever happened to him. Monica kept the square of linen. When the water was

MUDDY SHE STILL STRAINED IT HERSELF, AND WHEN THERE were grandchildren she stood them on a stool at her elbow and let them watch the wigglers kick in the cloth, and turned it out on the grass.

Mr. Hagan rode the circuit four more years. He died at St. Thomas in the winter of 1795 and was buried in the graveyard on the bluff, and his little Spanish book went to the nuns in the woods. They kept it until they went away to Baltimore in 1831, and took it with them.

Phillis told the story in the kitchen at the Edelen place and in the quarter on Saturday nights, and at the manor at St. Thomas, where her husband Ned belonged to the priests, so that she was given leave to walk over on Saturdays to see him. She told it the same way every time. She would come to the part where the young man could not find his wife, and stop, and say that she had known a good many men who could not see what was a yard in front of them, but that was the first time she ever saw one find it out. Then she would tell how the old priest put out his hand and touched the young man's hand, and say that was the whole of the sermon. The rest was talk.

Monica Boarman's square of linen is said to be in the family still, washed so many times that it is thin as a cobweb, and brown at the center from all the spring water that ever went through it, and folded small in a drawer, the way she folded it, with the four corners in.

Background

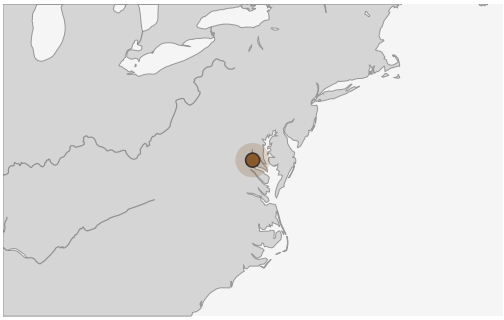
The verse

> *There is no fire like passion; there is no losing throw like hatred; there is no pain like this body; there is no happiness higher than rest.*
>
> Dhammapada 202, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the parents of a young woman of good family invite the Buddha and his monks to her wedding. The bride goes back and forth straining water for the monks and serving them, while the bridegroom stands and stares at her until desire overpowers him; he neglects the Buddha and the eighty great elders and makes up his mind to take her in his arms. The Buddha sees his thought and makes it so that he can no longer see her. Gazing instead at the Buddha, the young man hears that

there is no fire like passion, no wrong like hatred, no suffering like the aggregates of body and mind, and no happiness like peace. Both bride and groom enter the stream, and the Buddha lets them see each other once more. Monks in the Buddha's tradition strain their drinking water through cloth so as not to kill small creatures in it. Read the full commentary story.

The old priest's friar is St. John of the Cross (1542–1591), the Spanish Carmelite reformer and companion of Teresa of Ávila. The passage is from the sixth chapter of the first book of *The Ascent of Mount Carmel*, on what the desires do to the soul, in David Lewis's translation of 1864 as revised in the 1906 edition.



Port Tobacco, Maryland

Southern Maryland, 1791

Maryland was founded as a refuge for English Catholics, but by the eighteenth century its Catholics could not vote, hold office, worship in public or keep schools, so wealthy families sent their sons across the Atlantic to the Jesuit college at St. Omer and on to Liège, as John Carroll did. Jesuits rode a circuit of private chapels from plantation headquarters such as St. Thomas Manor on the bluff above the Port Tobacco River. The suppression of the Society of Jesus in 1773 left them priests without an order; the Society was restored in the United States at St. Thomas in 1805. Carroll was consecrated the first American bishop in August 1790. The Maryland Jesuits held enslaved people on their estates, among them some of the 272 men, women and children the province sold in 1838.

In July 1790 four Discalced Carmelite nuns sailed up the Chesapeake from Norfolk: Mother Bernardina Matthews, her nieces Ann Teresa and Susanna Matthews, all Maryland-born and trained in the Low Countries, and the Englishwoman Frances Dickenson. On October 15, 1790, the feast of St. Teresa, they moved onto a farm north of Port Tobacco, the first community of Catholic nuns in the new United States. Their house too was worked by enslaved people, forty-one of them in 1820. After 1830 the community moved to Baltimore. The Edelens, the Boarmans, Phillis, and Mr. Hagan in this story are invented.

After the story of a certain maiden of family from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 202). The original. St. John of the Cross, *The Ascent of Mount Carmel*, tr. David Lewis (1864; ed. 1906). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

15.5

Loaf Mass

I conjure thee, O Meal!
Who art indeed our body, since without thee
We could not live
— Aradia, or the Gospel of the Witches

C'est comme ça qu'on me l'a conté, on the Hartwell road.

I. The Gate

Hartwell, Oxford County, Maine · Saturday, August 2, 1986

Armand Gagnon was fifty-four and owned one ox. He had been born in Little Canada in Lewiston and had gone into the mill at sixteen, and when the mill let his shift go he came up to his uncle's place in Hartwell, forty acres of ledge and popple, and stayed. He lived in a trailer set on the old cellar. For money he twitched wood. A man with a skidder will not come out for six cords on a back lot, and will tear up the lot if he does, so the summer people and the widows hired Armand, who brought the logs out to the road one at a time on a chain behind the ox and left the ground looking as if nobody had been there. He was paid by the cord, when he was paid. He also witched wells with a forked apple stick, which cost nothing, because his mother had told him it would leave him if he took money for it.

The ox was a red Durham steer named Lion, said the French way, eight years old and a little over a ton, with a white star on his forehead. Armand's mémère had kept a story about a red cow with a star that you did not turn your back on. Lion had never stepped on so much as a chicken.

The people at the old Estes farm had come from Massachusetts in 1973. Their name was Lund. Armand found their water for them the next

spring, sixty feet down behind the barn where the stick said, and Meg Lund gave him a loaf of bread for it and told him, since he had asked about the sickle moon cut into the barn door, what they were. He was not troubled. He had been raised by nuns and had seen stranger. Twice he had gone up when they had their people in, and stood at the back of the field with his cap in his hand. Nobody had asked him to confess anything or sign anything, and afterward they had fed him.

That summer Meg told him a woman was coming up from Providence for the first of August, the loaf-mass, the day they kept for the first grain. She was a priestess of the old kind, Meg said, the kind that is trained and trains others, and she was bringing her own people in a van and three cars. When Meg had telephoned in June to ask her, the woman had said, *Yes. There is a man up there I have to see,* and had not said who.

You come hear her, Armand, Meg said. *Two o'clock.*

He meant to. He had his other shirt washed and on the line.

On Saturday morning he walked down at first light to Hackett's pasture, where Lion ran with the heifers for the price of fixing fence, and the gate chain was on the ground and the ox was gone.

He stood there with the goad stick in his hand. In the trailer there was coffee and nothing else. The cheese the government gave out at the Grange hall, the five-pound orange brick, had been finished Thursday, and the next giveaway was Tuesday. A woman in Paris Hill owed him for eleven cords and was in Connecticut until Labor Day. He had thought he would eat at the Lunds'.

He thought: *Do I look for the ox, or do I go hear the woman?* Without the ox there was no wood, and without the wood there was nothing. *The ox first,* he thought. *Then the woman.*

The tracks went up the tote road, and he went after them.

II. The Field

The Lund farm · two o'clock

There were about sixty of them that year, from Portland and Norway and as far as Bangor, and the twenty-two from Provid-

ence. The Maine people ate at noon on the grass, sandwiches and switchel, and offered the same to the Providence people, most of whom said no thank you. The feast was for after. It was laid out on planks under the maples with cheesecloth over it against the wasps. Brown bread steamed in coffee cans, corn waiting in its husks, three blueberry cakes. The loaf for the altar was baked in the shape of a sheaf, as long as a child. Down by the garden was the bean hole, where Tobias Lund had buried an iron kettle of yellow-eyes on a bed of coals the night before and shoveled the dirt back over it.

The woman from Providence was called Doris Almeida six days of the week. She was forty-nine and kept the books at a plant in Olneyville that made clasps and earring backs. In circle her people called her the Lady, and they were a little afraid of her. On a day when there was work to do she took water from sunrise and nothing else, and she expected the same of them. She had once sent a man home from his own initiation over a roll of Life Savers. In twelve years nobody had heard her ask what was for supper.

At two o'clock they came down to the hayfield, where a ring had been mown and four lanterns stood unlit at the quarters. The Lady walked to the edge of the ring in her black robe and stopped there.

The man I came up here for has gone into the woods after his ox, she said. *We will wait for him.*

She sat down on the stone wall. That was all she said.

By three the children had been let go to the pond. By four a man from Portland had looked at his watch a number of times and driven home. Her own people stood about in the heat with their robes hitched up, and Ronnie Paiva, who had worked the rites beside her for nine years, went over once and bent down and said something, and came back with his ears red. Meg Lund counted heads and thought about the town. Since that television program the year before last the town had opinions about the Lunds, and sixty cars along the road until dark would not improve them. But it was the Lady's rite to begin. Nobody else could cast, and she sat on the wall with her hands in her lap and looked at the gap in the trees where the tote road came down.

III. The Bean Hole

The same day · toward evening

He found Lion at four o'clock, two miles back, at a cellar hole on the old Whitcomb place where a Yellow Transparent still stood and dropped its apples in August. The ox was lying in the fern with his belly out like a barrel, chewing. Armand sat down beside him until his legs stopped shaking. He had been up the tote road and across the power line and around the beaver flowage twice, calling, and he had had nothing since the coffee. He ate four of the apples. They were mealy and they made it worse.

He got the ox up and walked him home by voice, and turned him in with Hackett's heifers and wired the gate chain shut with a double twist. By then it was past six. The trailer was a mile one way and the Lunds' a mile the other. *It will be over,* he thought. *But I can go and tell her I am sorry. I can do that much.* He did not go home. He went down the road as he was, with spruce pitch on his hands and burdock up one leg.

They were all still there. He saw the ring in the hayfield and the four lanterns dark, and the people sitting in the stubble, and he did not understand it. He took off his cap and stood at the edge.

Madame, he said to the woman on the wall, *I am sorry to be late. I had to find my ox.*

She looked at him. She looked for some time, at his face and then at his hands, which he could not keep still. Then she turned to Meg Lund.

Is there anything to eat?

Meg thought she had misheard. *The feast is for after, Lady. Nobody has touched it. The beans are still in the ground.*

Then dig them up, the Lady said, *and give this man his supper.*

She pointed to where he should sit, at the head of the planks under the maples. Tobias went for the shovel. They opened the bean hole in front of everyone, the dirt and then the grey ash and then the flat stone, and lifted the kettle out on a hook, and when the lid came off the smell of molasses and salt pork went across the field and sixty hungry people stood and breathed it. Meg filled a plate. She cut the brown bread. Somebody

stripped an ear of corn and ran with it to the house to boil. And the Lady went to the altar stone herself and picked up the sheaf loaf, which was to have been blessed and broken at the height of the rite, and broke it with her hands, and brought him the first piece.

He ate. Nobody else did. He ate two plates of beans and the bread and the corn when it came, and a square of the cake, with sixty people watching, and it did not occur to him to be ashamed, because none of them looked as if he should be. When he was done he went to the pump and rinsed his mouth and washed his face and his hands and came back with his hair wet.

Something in him had gone quiet. He had not known it was making noise.

Then she lit the lanterns. She cast the ring with salt and water and the knife, and called the quarters, and Armand stood inside it between a schoolteacher from Norway and a boy with a braid. She took what was left of the loaf and held it up in the last of the sun, and she taught. He followed it better than he had expected. She went in order, the way a person explains a job. The seed goes into the ground. It comes up and stands and is beautiful. It is cut. It is beaten and ground and put through the fire, and then it is this, and then it is you. Nothing that feeds anyone gets to stay what it was. A body is a thing put together out of what it ate, and it is coming apart the whole time, and it will be cut too. There is a way to look straight at that, she said, without flinching and without making a speech about it, and a person who has looked at it that way is not afraid of the knife or the fire and has nothing left to want.

Over the bread she said the old words.

I conjure thee, O Meal!
Who art indeed our body, since without thee
We could not live, thou who (at first as seed)
Before becoming flower went in the earth,
Where all deep secrets hide,

— Aradia, or the Gospel of the Witches, ch. II

Armand Gagnon stood in a hayfield with his stomach full and saw it. It was a plain thing. It had the same shape as the eleven cords and the orange cheese and the mill, and Lion on his side in the fern. Something that had been walking back and forth in him since Lewiston lay down. He could not have told it to anyone in either of his languages. The schoolteacher beside him saw his face and looked away, to leave him alone with it.

IV. The Road

Hartwell · dusk

They ate the rest of the feast by lantern. Afterward the Maine people walked the Providence people down the road to where the cars were, as far as the plank bridge, and said good night there and turned back.

Her own people came on behind her in the dusk, and they were sore. Ronnie Paiva said it, not very low.

Twelve years. Twelve years it's been water from sunup and not a crumb till the circle's open. I never once heard her ask what there was to eat. And today she holds sixty people in a field for four hours and then asks after supper, for a stranger, and feeds him off the altar before the ring is cast.

The Lady stopped in the road and turned around.

What are you saying back there?

They told her.

Yes, she said. *That is what I did. I drove six hours for that man. I saw in June that he was ready, and nobody else up here was. He got up before light with nothing in the house, and he spent the whole day in the woods on that nothing, hunting the one animal that keeps him alive. If I had cast at two without him, I'd have come for nothing. If I had started in on him at half past six the way he stood there, he would have heard his own stomach and not one word of mine. So I did what I did.*

Nobody answered her.

There is no sickness like hunger. Any other one, you can treat a person who has something in him. And there is no hurt like being a thing put together, that

has to be fed and comes apart anyway. Somebody who knows those two things the way they are, and not the way he'd like them, has the best there is to have. He has it tonight. The ones who made the hymn to the grain mother knew what it was worth.

> *Happy is he among men upon earth who has seen these mysteries;*
>
> *— Homeric Hymn to Demeter*

Then she got into the van, and Ronnie Paiva drove.

Armand went home the other way. Meg had wrapped the heel of the sheaf loaf in a square of the cheesecloth and put it in his shirt pocket. At Hackett's gate he stopped and tried the chain. The heifers were lying down. Lion got up out of the dark and came over to the fence and put his wet nose through the wire, and Armand took out the heel of the loaf and broke it. He gave the ox the bigger half, since it was the ox who had found the apple tree.

Background

The verse

> *Hunger is the worst of diseases, the body the greatest of pains; if one knows this truly, that is Nirvana, the highest happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 203, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the Buddha sees at dawn that a certain poor man of Āḷavī is ready to understand, and walks thirty leagues with his monks to teach him. The man means to come and listen, but that morning his ox strays, and he decides to find the ox first. The townspeople feed the monks and wait for the sermon; the Buddha says he will not speak until the man he came for returns, and sits silent. The man finds his ox late in the day, drives it back to the herd, and comes straight to the Buddha without going home to eat. The Buddha asks the steward whether any food is left and has the man seated and fed before he teaches him. The commentary notes that this is the only time on record that the Buddha asked about food. When the monks grumble about it on the road, he turns around, explains that a hungry man cannot take in the teaching, and speaks the verse. Where Müller has "the body," the Pāli word is *saṅkhārā*, all things that are put together. Read the full commentary story.

Oxford County, Maine

Oxford County, Maine, 1986

Wicca reached the United States from England in the 1960s and spread through covens whose priestesses trained their successors. Its eight seasonal festivals include Lammas, the "loaf-mass" of the first grain on the first of August. In most covens the shared food comes after the rite, and many fast beforehand. Charles Godfrey Leland's *Aradia, or the Gospel of the Witches* (1899), with its conjuration of the meal for the witches' supper, was one of the texts the early Wiccans drew on; the ancient Homeric Hymn to Demeter is quoted here in H. G. Evelyn-White's translation of 1914. The middle 1980s were the years of the Satanic panic, when television specials taught rural neighbors to be afraid of people like the Lunds. In 1986 a federal appeals court held, in *Dettmer v. Landon*, that Wicca is a religion under the First Amendment.

The textile and shoe mills of Lewiston were worked for a century by French Canadians who settled the tenement district called Little Canada, and who were laid off in their thousands as the mills closed after the 1950s. In the Maine woods the diesel skidder replaced horses and oxen in the 1960s, though a few teamsters went on working small lots where a machine would do damage. From 1981 the Department of Agriculture gave away its surplus dairy stocks to the poor in five-pound blocks, the "government cheese" handed out at Grange halls and firehouses. Beans baked overnight in an iron kettle buried on coals are an old Maine supper. Hartwell and its people are invented.

After the story of a certain lay disciple from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 203). The original. Sacred texts from Charles Godfrey Leland's *Aradia, or the Gospel of the Witches* (1899) and the Homeric Hymn to Demeter, tr. H. G. Evelyn-White (1914). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

15.6

The Last Course

> *There is no riches above a sound body, and no joy above the joy of the heart.*
> *— Ecclesiasticus 30:16*

Ainsi je l'ai entendu, in the kitchens under Fifth Avenue.

I. Breakfast

Fifth Avenue, New York · January 1884

Josiah Ruland ate breakfast at half past eight in a room panelled in walnut, under a painting of a stag at bay, and on an ordinary weekday it went like this. A dozen Blue Points on the half shell. A porterhouse steak. Two mutton chops, because the steak was never enough by itself. Four eggs, shirred. Fried potatoes, a stack of buckwheat cakes with butter and Vermont syrup, a dish of stewed kidneys if the cook had them, rolls, and a pot of coffee with a pitcher of cream. He did not think of this as a large breakfast. He thought of it as breakfast. His father had been a canal-boat captain on the Lehigh who ate cornmeal mush out of a tin plate, and Josiah Ruland had made his own money out of the anthracite, and the coal roads, and the iron, and every morning he sat down to that table like a man settling an account.

He was fifty-eight that winter. He had been the best rider in his club when he was forty, and now he could not mount a horse without a block and a groom, and he had not been out with the hounds in four seasons. He wheezed on the stairs. He slept badly at night and heavily in the day, in the library, in his carriage, in the pew at Grace Church through the whole of the sermon, and when he woke his mouth was sour and his temper was worse.

His temper fell, most mornings, on his nephew.

Christopher Ruland was twenty-eight and his uncle's private secretary, which meant he opened the letters, kept the engagements, carried the papers to the directors' meetings at the office on Wall Street and was spoken to in front of the clerks like a boy who had broken a window. He was the son of Josiah's younger brother Will, who had been a partner in the first mines and had gone to the war and been mortally wounded at Cold Harbor. In the spring of 1865 Josiah had bought Will's shares from his widow for a fair price, he always said, a fair price for the time. Kit had been eight years old and had not thought about it until he was twenty, and since he was twenty he had thought about little else. He did not say it. He did not need to. It was in the way he laid the letters on the desk.

There was a daughter, too, Adela, who was twenty-two, and grave, and fond of her cousin, and the two of them had been forbidden to speak of it since the summer.

On the second Monday of January Josiah Ruland finished his breakfast, called for his carriage, and told Kit to come with him and bring the cheque-book. He was going down to Rivington Street.

II. The Dispensary

Rivington Street · the same morning

THE DISPENSARY WAS IN THE GROUND FLOOR OF A TENEMENT east of the Bowery, two rooms and a hall, with a bench along the wall of the hall and a stove at the end of it, and it had been there for eleven years. Ruland's wife Cornelia had given the money to open it, before she died, and Ruland went on paying the rent and the coal and the doctor's small salary because Cornelia had asked him to, and once a quarter he went down to look at it, the way he looked at a mine.

The doctor was Hester Ashdown. She was sixty-one years old, the daughter of a country rector in Connecticut, and she had taken her degree at the Female Medical College in Philadelphia in 1857, when the men students at the other colleges in that city still hissed women in the street. In the war she had been one of Miss Dix's nurses, who had to be

over thirty-five and plain, and she said she had qualified on both counts with room to spare. She had nursed the wounded from the Wilderness and from Cold Harbor in the long sheds at Fredericksburg and in the river hospitals, and she had been in the ward where they brought the officers from the Second Corps, and she had sat one night with a captain named Ruland who was asking for his boy. She had never told the uncle this. She had told the nephew, once, years ago, when he was a student and came down with his aunt's Christmas parcels, and he had never told anyone either.

She was with a patient when they came in, and the bench was full of women from the street with babies in shawls, so Ruland walked. He walked up the hall and down it in his sealskin coat, with his hat in his hand, breathing hard. He looked like a man who had been sent for and could not remember why. He stopped by the stove. His eyes kept closing. He would not lie down on anything in that place and he would not sit among the women, and after a time a young Polish mother moved her two children onto her lap and made room for him at the end of the bench without a word, and he sat. In two minutes his chin was on his chest. The babies watched him.

When the doctor came out at last she stood in front of him until he woke.

Did you come here before you'd had your sleep, Mr. Ruland?

I've slept, he said. *I'm always like this after a meal. It's a misery to me. I've had the best men on Madison Avenue and they give me pills and send me to Saratoga for the waters.*

She looked at him a while, at the coat and the colour of his face and the way his chest moved. She did not take his pulse. She said she supposed he had eaten a good breakfast.

He told her what he had eaten. Kit, standing by the door, listened to the list go by and watched the faces of the women on the bench, who were eating, that winter, bread and tea and herring when there was herring.

Well, said Dr. Ashdown. *That is what eating like that does. It brings exactly this.* And she said it to him, plainly, the way she would have told him he had a fever.

> *Sound sleep cometh of moderate eating: he riseth early, and his wits are with him: but the pain of watching, and choler, and pangs of the belly, are with an unsatiable man.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 31:20*

Ruland said that his wife's father had been fond of quoting the Apocrypha too.

Then you know there's more of it, she said, and gave him the rest of what she had to give him, which was the same thing from further on in the same book. A man should know the measure of what he eats. He should be watchful at the table the way he would be watchful at a contract. And if he were, he would have fewer pains, and age slowly, and keep his life.

He tried to say it back to her and could not hold it. He could have told her the price of a ton of egg coal at tidewater in every month since 1859, and he could not keep three lines of Ecclesiasticus in his head for the length of the hall.

So she went into the back room and took a prescription blank off the pad, and wrote on it, and came out and gave it, not to him, but to Kit.

Learn this, she said.

Kit read it. *And when I've learned it, Doctor, what do I do with it?*

At dinner, when your uncle comes to the last course, and he has his fork in his hand, you say it to him. Out loud, at the table. He'll understand you. He'll put it down. And in the morning you take the card from that dinner down to the kitchen, and you draw a line through that course, and you tell the cook that tonight it isn't to be made at all.

And the next night?

The same, with whatever is last.

Until when? Until he's eating bread and water?

Until he can get up from the table and walk to the top of his own stairs without stopping on the landing, said Dr. Ashdown. *Then leave it where it is.*

Ruland looked at the two of them. He did not like to be talked over. But he had been talked over by the men on Madison Avenue too, and paid them for it, and they had never said anything to him half so plain. He took out the cheque-book and wrote a cheque to the dispensary and gave it to her, and she thanked him and put it in her apron pocket without looking at it, and went back to the women on the bench.

III. The Card

Fifth Avenue · winter and spring 1884

Even when the family dined alone in that house there were nine courses, and when there was company there were thirteen or fourteen, and every dinner had its card in a silver holder by each plate, written out in French in the hand of Monsieur Achille Bréval, who had cooked for an ambassador in Paris and for Mr. Ruland for nine years and was paid, the servants said, more than the president of a bank. The card for that Monday read: oysters; a clear turtle soup; a timbale of sweetbreads; a turbot with lobster sauce; a saddle of mutton with French beans; terrapin in the Maryland style; a sorbet of Roman punch; canvasback duck with fried hominy and celery; and an iced pudding with fruits and bonbons.

Ruland came down to it in a bad humour, and Adela came down in a grey silk, and Kit came down with a paper folded small in his waistcoat pocket. They went through it. They always went through it. The servants came and went. The candles burned in the silver. When the iced pudding came round, molded like a castle, and the footman set a slice of it before Ruland and he took up his spoon, Kit put down his own.

> *Be not unsatiable in any dainty thing, nor too greedy upon meats: For excess of meats bringeth sickness, and surfeiting will turn into choler. By surfeiting have many perished; but he that taketh heed prolongeth his life.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 37:29–31*

He said it to the tablecloth the first time, and his voice was not steady. Adela stared at him. The footman stood like a post. Ruland held his spoon above the plate and looked at his nephew down the length of the table, and the look went on so long that Kit thought he would be put out of the house that night. Then Ruland laid the spoon down beside the plate, and pushed the plate an inch away with two fingers, and got up.

He went into the library and sat down at the desk and wrote out a cheque to the Rivington Street Dispensary for one hundred dollars, and sealed it in an envelope, and rang for a man to take it down in the morning. Then he went up to bed. He stopped twice on the stairs.

In the morning Kit went down to the kitchen with the card. He had never been in his uncle's kitchen. It was the size of a chapel, tiled white to the ceiling, with copper on every wall and a range as long as a railway car, and Monsieur Achille stood at the end of it in his white cap and looked at the young gentleman as if he were a rat that had come up the dumbwaiter. Kit drew a line through the iced pudding with a pencil and explained. Monsieur Achille said several things in French that Kit, who had studied French at Columbia, mostly understood.

That night there was no pudding. The last course was the canvasback. When Ruland lifted his fork to it, Kit said the verse again, steadier, and Ruland laid down the fork and pushed the plate away and went and wrote the cheque. In the morning Kit drew a line through the canvasback.

It went on like that. The sorbet went. The terrapin went, and Monsieur Achille said that in his professional life he had never been so insulted, and gave notice, and withdrew it the same afternoon. The saddle of mutton went. Every night Kit said it, and every night the old man heard it to the end with his fork in the air, and put the fork down, and went into the library and wrote a cheque for a hundred dollars to the dispensary, and the envelope went down to Rivington Street in the morning. Below stairs they began to call it the Doctor's course. The second footman, who was from Cork, said the old man was being read his sentence nightly like a felon in the dock, and the butler told him to hold his tongue.

On the nineteenth night the card in the silver holder had three lines on it: a soup; a chop with potatoes; an apple. Ruland ate the soup and the

chop, and when Kit opened his mouth to speak he looked at the apple and put up his hand and said, *I know.* And he got up and went out into the hall and climbed the stairs, slowly, one hand on the rail, all the way to the top, without stopping on the landing. Kit stood at the bottom and watched him do it.

In the morning Kit took the card down to the kitchen and did not draw a line through anything. He told Monsieur Achille it was to stay as it was. Monsieur Achille looked at the three lines for a long time, and then he said that if he was only to have a soup and a chop and an apple to cook, then by God they would be the best soup and the best chop and the best apple in the city of New York, and they were.

The card stayed at three lines. When there was company, the company had their fourteen courses and Ruland had his three, and the company talked about it afterward in their carriages, and he did not care. The cheques went on. They went on through Lent and Easter and into the spring. With them Dr. Ashdown took the second floor of the tenement and put eight beds in it for lying-in, and hired a nurse, and paid a woman on the fourth floor to keep a stove going for the hot water.

By May Ruland had let out his waistcoats twice the other way. He sat through the sermon at Grace Church awake, with his arms folded, and found he disagreed with most of it. He began to taste his food. It surprised him. He said to Kit one evening, over the chop, as if he were reporting a discovery in the coalfields, that mutton tasted of mutton.

IV. The Sauceboat

Fifth Avenue · April

Cornelia Ruland's diamond had been lost on New Year's night.

It was a single stone the size of a hazelnut on a fine gold chain, which Ruland had bought in Paris the year the first mine paid, and which Cornelia had worn at every dinner of her married life, and which Adela wore now. On New Year's night, at a dinner for twenty-four, the clasp had given way, and the stone had gone somewhere between the soup and the

ices, and was not found. The rugs were taken up. The chairs were turned over. The detectives came from the Pinkerton office and talked to the servants one by one in the butler's pantry. Ruland dismissed the second footman, a boy named Daly who had served Adela's side of the table and had the misfortune to have a brother who had been in the Tombs, and Daly went out of the area door in January without a character, and Adela cried, and Ruland said that was what came of it.

In April, when the turbot had been off the card for two months and Monsieur Achille had given up hoping it would come back, the butler had the fish service brought out of the pantry to be wrapped in flannel and put away in the strong room for the summer. It was a great silver set, the fish dishes and the slices and the sauceboats, and when the under-butler turned the big sauceboat over to polish the foot, something rolled out of the scroll under the handle where the lobster sauce had dried around it on New Year's night, and rang on the pantry table, and lay there in the gaslight.

Ruland sent Kit to find Daly. It took Kit nine days and most of the Fourth Ward. He found him at last unloading oranges on a pier on South Street, and brought him back up the avenue in a hansom, and Ruland gave him his place again and his back wages and a letter in his own hand that Daly kept in his pocket for the rest of his life and showed to anyone who doubted him.

V. Grace Church

Broadway and Long Island · June to October

The quarrel did not end in a day. It ended a little each night, at the table, over the card. A man cannot say the same words to another man every evening for three weeks, and be obeyed, without something changing between them. Kit found he could not hate a man who put down his fork when he was asked. Ruland found that the boy he had spoken to like a clerk for six years had a voice he did not mind hearing. One evening in the library, with the cheque drying on the blotter, he said without looking up that Will's shares had been worth twice what he had

PAID FOR THEM IN '65, AND HE HAD KNOWN IT, AND HE HAD told himself it was a fair price for the time. Kit said nothing for a while. Then he said that he knew it too, and that he had known for eight years, and that he was tired of knowing it.

In June, Ruland gave his daughter to his nephew at Grace Church, with a bishop and the choir and half of Washington Square in the pews and a crowd on Broadway outside the railings to see the dresses go in. There were people who said first cousins ought not to marry and people who said the Rulands had done it to keep the money in the family, and both kinds of people came to the wedding. Ruland walked Adela up the aisle under his own power, and stood at the rail without leaning on it. He gave the young couple the place on Long Island, the white house with the pond below the lawn where Adela had learned to swim as a child, so that she would have, he said, her own water to bathe in, and he made Kit a partner in the firm, on the same terms as his father had been.

In the summer he asked Dr. Ashdown whether she had any family that wanted a place. She had a grand-niece, it turned out, Nell, the daughter of a nephew who had gone west and done poorly and died, a sharp girl of nineteen who had taught herself the type-writing machine. Ruland took her into the house to keep his correspondence and the accounts of his charities, which were now considerable, and she sat in Kit's old chair at the desk in the library and rattled at a Remington from nine to five and put the cheques in their envelopes. He did not ask who her mother had been. Dr. Ashdown, who would have told him, was not asked.

In September he rode again. He went out to the Meadow Brook country on Long Island and hired a big steady bay from a dealer at Hempstead, and on a grey morning in October he was out with the hounds over the plains, a lean man in an old scarlet coat that had been taken in by a tailor on Twenty-third Street, and he took the first wall clean and the second one badly and stayed on. He came home with mud to his collar and ate a chop and an apple and slept nine hours.

At the end of that month the money men of the city gave a dinner at Delmonico's for Mr. Blaine, who was running for president, and Ruland was asked, and sent his regrets. The next morning the *World* printed a

cartoon across its front page of the millionaires at the dinner feasting like Belshazzar while a working man and his wife and child begged for the crumbs, and the Democrats passed the menu of the dinner from hand to hand as if it were an indictment. Monsieur Achille read the menu in the kitchen aloud to the staff, all of it, the oysters and the terrapin and the canvasback and the ices, in a voice of deep contempt.

VI. The Bench

Rivington Street · November 1884

Ruland went down to Rivington Street the week after the election, on foot from the elevated at Grand Street, in the cold, with no one with him. The bench was full, as it was always full, and he did not walk up and down this time. He sat at the end of it, among the women, with his hat on his knee, and waited his turn like anyone, and a little girl in a red hood sat next to him and looked at his watch-chain for half an hour while he let her.

When Dr. Ashdown came out and saw him she brought him back into the small room and gave him the patients' chair and sat down at her desk.

Doctor, he said, *I have come to tell you I'm a happy man. I don't believe I have been one before.*

She waited.

He told her. He told it like a report to his directors, item by item, as if he were afraid of leaving something out. He was well. He slept. He could ride again, and had taken a wall on Long Island at fifty-eight with men half his age watching, and had not fallen off. He had quarrelled with his brother's son for six years, and now his brother's son had his daughter and his brother's share, and they did not quarrel, and he had not known how much the quarrel cost him until it stopped. His wife's diamond, which had been lost, had come back to him, out of a sauceboat, if she could believe it, and he had been able to give a boy back his name. And he had her own niece's child in his house, which he had done because he wished her to know that he did not hold himself apart from her, and the girl was the best secretary he had ever had and kept him honest.

He stopped. He looked at his hands, which were thinner, and at the cheap clock on her desk.

Dr. Ashdown sat a while. Then she said it to him, from the same book, the way she said everything, as if she were telling him the dose.

> *Better is the poor, being sound and strong of constitution, than a rich man that is afflicted in his body. Health and good estate of body are above all gold, and a strong body above infinite wealth. There is no riches above a sound body, and no joy above the joy of the heart.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 30:14–16*

And when he had heard it and was getting up, she gave him one thing more, about the nephew, and he stood holding his hat and heard that too.

> *A faithful friend is the medicine of life; and they that fear the Lord shall find him.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 6:16*

The joy of the heart, he said. *I don't know what that is, Doctor. I'm an old coal man.*

No, she said. *Not yet. But you've stopped standing in front of it.*

• • •

He went out into the hall. The light was going. Somebody had lit the gas, and the women on the bench were wrapped up in their shawls with the children asleep on them, waiting, and the stove ticked, and the little girl in the red hood had gone in to the doctor with her mother. He stood by the stove a minute buttoning his coat.

Then he took out of his breast pocket the thing he had carried there since the spring, which was the prescription blank from January, in Hester Ashdown's hand, gone soft as a handkerchief from being taken out and read at the table and folded and put away again, and the card from the nineteenth night, with its three lines in Monsieur Achille's French: a soup; a chop; an apple. He put the card back in his pocket. The

prescription he folded once more and laid on the warm iron of the stove shelf, where the doctor would find it, for the next one.

Background

The verses

> *If a man becomes fat and a great eater, if he is sleepy and rolls himself about, that fool, like a hog fed on wash, is born again and again.*
>
> Dhammapada 325, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Health is the greatest of gifts, contentedness the best riches; trust is the best of relationships, Nirvana the highest happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 204, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi of Kosala eats rice by the bucketful and comes to the Buddha so heavy with sleep that he paces up and down rather than lie down. The Buddha warns him with a verse about the overeater who rolls about like a fattened hog, then gives him a verse on knowing the measure in food. The king cannot memorize it, so the Buddha has his nephew Sudassana learn it and recite it at every meal just as the king is about to take the last ball of rice; the king throws the ball away, and the next meal is cooked with that many fewer grains. Each time he hears the verse he gives a thousand coins in alms. He grows lean and cheerful, and returns to tell the Buddha that he can hunt again, that he has made peace with his nephew by giving him his daughter Vajirā, that a lost jewel has come back to him, and that he has taken a daughter of the Buddha's own kin into his household. The Buddha answers that health is the greatest gain, contentment the greatest wealth, trust the best kin, and nibbāna the highest happiness. Read the full commentary story, or about Pasenadi.

Fifth Avenue, New York

New York, 1884

In the Gilded Age a formal dinner in a rich New York house ran to a dozen courses or more, set out on a card written in French: oysters, a soup, fish, entrées, a roast, a Roman punch to clear the palate, game such as canvasback duck, terrapin, ices and sweets. The great public table of the city was Delmonico's, then at Fifth Avenue and Twenty-sixth Street. On the night of October 29, 1884, days before the presidential election, a crowd of the city's millionaires gave a dinner there for the Republican candidate, James G. Blaine. The next morning the *New York World* ran Walt McDougall's front-page cartoon "The Royal Feast of Belshazzar Blaine and the Money Kings," in which a laborer and his family beg for crumbs from the table; Democrats circulated the menu, and the dinner is often counted among the causes of Blaine's narrow defeat. The Meadow Brook Club, founded on Long Island in 1881, gave the rich a polo ground and a hunt.

Women physicians were still rare and often unwelcome. The Female Medical College of Pennsylvania, founded in 1850, was the second school in the world to train women for the M.D., and many of its graduates worked in free dispensaries for poor women and children in the immigrant wards of the cities. In the Civil War, Dorothea Dix recruited some 3,000 nurses for the Union Army and asked that they be between thirty-five and fifty and plain-looking. The Ruland family, Dr. Ashdown and her dispensary, Monsieur Achille and the diamond are invented. Ecclesiasticus, the Wisdom of Jesus the son of Sirach, is one of the books of the Apocrypha, which the Episcopal Church read in its lessons and the King James translators set between the Testaments.

After the story of King Pasenadi of Kosala from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 204 and 325). The original. Scripture from Ecclesiasticus in the Apocrypha of the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

15.7

The Cure Chair

> *And the true philosophers, Simmias, are always occupied in the practice of dying, wherefore also to them least of all men is death terrible.*
> — *Plato, Phaedo*

As it was told on the porches, on Helen Hill.

I. Four Months

Pelletier Cottage, Helen Hill, Saranac Lake, New York · June 1925

Mrs. Pelletier's was a tall brown house on Helen Hill with three porches stacked on the front of it, one to a floor, and twelve cure chairs on the porches. Fourteen people boarded there that year at twenty-two dollars a week with trays. They had come up from offices and schoolrooms and one from a ribbon counter in Utica, each with a spot on an X-ray plate, to lie out of doors eight hours a day in every weather the Adirondacks had and wait for the lung to heal. It was called curing. A person was on the cure, or cheating the cure, and the whole of medicine was in the difference.

Miss Agnes Thayer had the front room on the first floor. She was fifty-four. She had taught Greek and Latin for twenty-two years at a girls' school downstate, and she had been in Saranac Lake for nine, which made her what the village called a chronic. Every afternoon when rest hour was over and the four o'clock temperatures were written down, she read aloud from her chair on the bottom porch until the supper trays came. She read Plato, in Jowett's English, a volume at a time. Whoever was allowed out of bed came down in coats and blankets to hear it, and

those who were not lay on the porches above and got what came up through the floor.

She did not lecture. If someone asked what a thing meant, she read it again more slowly. To each new boarder she said one thing, the first week, and did not repeat it.

You are going to lie still for a year. You had better learn to be there while you do it.

On the fifth of June she finished a page of the *Republic*, shut the book on her finger, and told them that Dr. Ames gave her about four months.

I tell you so that you needn't have it from Mrs. Pelletier. We shall have time for the Phaedo*, I think.*

Then the trays came.

II. The North End

June to September

Nobody ate. The old hands, the ones with three and four winters in, went quiet and were suddenly particular about their own hours, since they knew to the week what four months was. The new ones cried where they sat. The girl from Utica cried so that she brought on a cough, and had to be put to bed. For days afterward they stood about in twos and threes on the stair landings, where they were not supposed to stand at all, and asked each other what was to be done.

A great deal was done. There was a list on the hall table of who would sit with her, hour by hour, so that she should never be on the porch alone. The women sewed balsam pillows, the kind the village sold to tourists, until she had eleven. There were flowers from the florist every Saturday. A subscription went round for a shelf of the classics in her name at the Free Library, and a man on the second floor who had been a sign painter lettered the plate for it. Her porch was full from the minute she was wheeled out, and they talked to her, kindly and without stopping, and when she read now they sat so close that the ones upstairs heard nothing. Even rest hour was whispered through. It tired her a good deal, and she thanked them.

Walter Tice did none of it.

He was twenty-nine and had been a clerk in an insurance office in Hartford, and he had been at Mrs. Pelletier's since November without curing a single day. His four o'clock ran a hundred and two-tenths as regularly as a clock. He played pinochle through rest hour on the second-floor porch. He walked down to the Pontiac on Broadway for the pictures when he was meant to be flat, and smoked, and knew a taxi man who could get Canadian whisky, and was cousining with a girl at a cottage on Franklin Avenue. The one hour of the day he never missed was Miss Thayer's. He liked it better than the pictures. He had come to believe that lying near her while she read was doing him the same good as doing what she said.

On the night of the fifth of June he lay awake on the sleeping porch and thought it through.

If she is gone in four months and I am still running a hundred at four, then all I ever had of her was the pleasure of listening. Whatever she has, I had better get it while she is here to tell me whether I've got it.

In the morning he gave his cigarettes to the tray boy. He had his chair moved up to the north end of the top porch, which nobody wanted, since it got no sun after one and looked at nothing but Baker Mountain. He took his trays there. He kept every hour on the card, eight in the chair and the two of rest hour dead flat without a book, and the milk and the raw eggs between meals, and when Dr. Ames after a month allowed him ten minutes' walking he walked ten minutes by his watch, up Helen Street and back, alone. He stopped talking. He answered the nurse and the doctor and otherwise said nothing to anyone, at first because talk made him cough and afterward because he found he had no use for it.

And he did the other half, which was hers. He lay there and tried to be there. His mind went down to Broadway forty times an hour, and to Hartford, and to the girl on Franklin Avenue, and each time he fetched it back to the chair and the blanket and the mountain. For weeks it was like calling a dog that will not come. Then, some afternoons, it stayed.

He did not go down for the reading. At half past four he could hear, two floors below, that she had begun. He could not hear the words.

Tice, what has got into you? they asked him on the stairs. *She's dying. You haven't been down once.*

He nodded to them and went on up.

III. No Feeling

The bottom porch · October

On the seventh of October Christy Mathewson died in his house up on Park Avenue, and for a week there was not a cut flower to be had in the village at any price. Pelletier Cottage found chrysanthemums for her anyway.

It was the sign painter and two of the women who said it to her at last, and they meant it kindly.

Mr. Tice has no feeling for you at all, Miss Thayer. Four months, and he has not come down those stairs. He hasn't signed the list. He never so much as put his name to the shelf.

She asked whether Mr. Tice still kept his hours. They said he kept nothing else.

Ask him to come down tomorrow at half past four. If his chart allows.

He came down in his overcoat with his blanket over his arm. She was propped on a back-rest with the eleven pillows ranged along the porch rail behind her and the chrysanthemums in a pail, and she had gone the color of the pages she read from. All fourteen were there, and they made room for him grudgingly.

Mr. Tice. I am told you have kept away from me since June. Why is that?

It was the first he had spoken to any of them in four months, and his voice was not used to it.

You said four months. I'd been here seven and never cured a day. I liked your hour, and I took that for the same thing as doing what you told me. So I thought I had four months to find out whether I could do it, while there was still somebody to ask.

And can you?

My four o'clock has been normal for nineteen days. That isn't what I mean.

No, Miss Thayer said. *I know what you mean. Well done, Mr. Tice.*

She looked along the rail at the pillows.

You have all been very good to me. I have more pillows than I have a head for. But I should like one thing understood while I am able to say it. Mr. Tice is the only one of you who has paid me any attention.

The book was open on her knees at a place near the end. She had been keeping it for them.

> *When he had done speaking, Crito said: And have you any commands for us, Socrates—anything to say about your children, or any other matter in which we can serve you?*
>
> *Nothing particular, Crito, he replied: only, as I have always told you, take care of yourselves; that is a service which you may be ever rendering to me and mine and to all of us, whether you promise to do so or not.*
>
> *— Plato, Phaedo, tr. Benjamin Jowett*

Nobody on the porch said anything. The girl from Utica took her name off the list that evening and went to bed at eight.

IV. Four O'Clock

The same porch, and the top one

SHE KEPT HIM BACK WHEN THE TRAYS CAME AND THE OTHERS had gone in.

What is it like, up at your end?

He tried to tell her and could not. He said it was like the house after everybody has gone to the pictures. He said that was wrong, too.

It is in here, she said, and turned back sixty pages without having to look for it, and read it to him alone, with the light going.

> *But when returning into herself she reflects, then she passes into the other world, the region of purity, and eternity, and immortality, and unchangeableness, which are her kindred, and with them she ever lives, when she is by herself and is not let or hindered; then she ceases from her erring ways, and being in communion with the unchanging is unchanging. And this state of the soul is called wisdom?*
>
> *— Plato, Phaedo, tr. Benjamin Jowett*

He had sat down on the porch step to listen. When she stopped he found that it had stayed, the thing that stayed some afternoons, and that it was not going to go. He had been afraid since a doctor in Hartford held a plate up to a window and showed him the spot. He had been afraid of her dying, all summer, two floors over her head. He looked for the fear now where he was used to finding it, and there was the porch, and the pail of chrysanthemums, and a woman shutting a book.

Go up, Mr. Tice, she said. *You will miss your hour.*

He climbed the two flights at the pace Dr. Ames allowed. At the north end he got into the chair and wrapped himself the way the nurse had taught him the first week and he had never troubled to do, the blanket under and over, left side, right side, feet, until nothing was out but his face. Baker Mountain had the last of the light on it. He lay there done up like something laid out for burial, in the cold, by himself, and he had never in his life been so comfortable.

Background

The verse

> *He who has tasted the sweetness of solitude and tranquillity, is free from fear and free from sin, while he tastes the sweetness of drinking in the law.*
>
> Dhammapada 205, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha tells the monks at Vesālī that in four months he will pass away. Seven hundred of them are shaken. Those who have not reached the goal cannot hold back their tears, and they go about in little groups asking one another what they are to do. One monk, the elder Tissa, reasons that he is not yet free and

had better become so while his teacher is alive. He keeps to himself and stops speaking with anyone. The others ask him why and get no answer, and they report to the Buddha that Tissa has no affection for him. The Buddha sends for Tissa, hears his reason, and says, "Well done." Then he tells the rest that only one who acts like Tissa truly loves him: those who honor him with perfumes and garlands do not honor him, and those who practice what he taught do. He speaks the verse, and Tissa reaches the goal. Read the full commentary story.

Saranac Lake, New York

Saranac Lake, 1925

Before antibiotics the best treatment anyone had for tuberculosis of the lungs was rest, food and cold clean air, kept up for months or years. Edward Livingston Trudeau, a consumptive doctor who had recovered in the Adirondacks, opened his sanitarium at Saranac Lake in the 1880s, and the village grew into the country's best-known cure town. Most patients boarded in private cure cottages, houses built or rebuilt with open porches where they lay out in every season on wide reclining cure chairs made in the village. Many of the cottages stood on Helen Hill. A patient's day was ruled by the thermometer and the clock: hours in the chair, a silent rest period after dinner, exercise allowed by the minute once the afternoon fever was gone. Romances between patients were called cousining. Pelletier Cottage and its people are invented.

The pitcher Christy Mathewson, one of the most admired ballplayers of his day, came to Saranac Lake with tuberculosis and died there on October 7, 1925, the day the World Series opened; both teams wore black armbands. The book Miss Thayer reads is Plato's *Phaedo*, the account of Socrates' last day in prison, in Benjamin Jowett's translation. Socrates spends the day arguing that a philosopher's whole life is "the practice of dying," and when his friend Crito asks at the end what they can do for him, he gives the answer quoted in the story.

After the story of the elder Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 205). The original. Scripture from Plato's *Phaedo* in the translation of Benjamin Jowett. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

15.8

Thousand Eyes

> *There is one glory of the sun, and another glory of the moon, and another glory of the stars; for one star differeth from another star in glory.*
> *— 1 Corinthians 15:41*

Now this is the way I heard it, sugar, in the dressing room off Second Avenue.

I. Bellevue

Bellevue, Tennessee · April 1987

By Easter she could not get to the bathroom anymore, so the girls rented a hospital bed from the medical supply on Charlotte Pike and set it up in the front room of the little house in Bellevue, where the window looked out on the dogwood and the light was best. They took her bed apart and leaned it against the wall of the back bedroom. They hung her dresses in that closet, all of them, the sequins and the beaded gowns and the white fox stole, so she could see them through the door if she turned her head.

Her name on the lease was Clayton Bivens. She had been born in Marshall County in 1936 and raised in the Church of Christ, where they sang without instruments because the New Testament did not mention any, and she had a voice that could hold a note under a tin roof until the old men looked up from their hymnals. She did hair on Belmont Boulevard for thirty years. On Friday and Saturday nights for fifteen of them she had been Miss Glory Darlene at the Satin Slipper off Second Avenue, and before that at places with no names, in basements, in the back rooms of beer joints out on the Murfreesboro Road where you went in through the kitchen. She had taken in more children than anyone could count. Boys

whose fathers had put them out on the highway with a grocery sack. Boys who came down from Kentucky on the Greyhound with eleven dollars. She had fed them, found them a room, taught them to sew a hem and walk in a heel and keep their mouths shut at the wrong times and open at the right ones. They called her Mama. Some of them were in the ground already, at Spring Hill and at little country churches whose preachers would not say their names at the graveside. Some of them were taking turns in the front room now.

The doctor at Vanderbilt had a name for what was in her bowels, a parasite that would not have troubled a well person for a week. In her it would not stop. It came eight, ten, fifteen times a day. It had taken forty pounds off her since February. The smell of it was in the curtains and the carpet and the girls' hair, and no amount of Lysol or lemon Pledge or Jean Naté would put it out.

They were good about it, mostly. Marva came after her shift at the nursing home on Gallatin Road and did the hard part, the washing and the turning, with her gloves on and her face set. Marva was the only one of them who had ever done it for money. Danny, who was Miss Dinah Shore Leave on Saturdays, did the laundry and cried in the laundry room where she couldn't hear. Little Luis from El Paso, who was nineteen and called himself Lupe Starr, sat by the bed and read her the TV Guide. But the bedpan they passed among themselves at arm's length like a hot dish, and each one of them, when it was his turn, carried it to the toilet with his face turned away and his breath held.

She saw it. She did not say anything. In 1987 there were nurses in Nashville who left the meal trays on the floor outside the door.

II. The Visitor

The front room · Tuesday night

A little after midnight on the Tuesday after Easter a white rental car pulled into the gravel by the carport. Luis looked through the blind and saw a man get out in a tan windbreaker and a seed cap, with no luggage, and stand in the yard a moment looking at the dark

HOUSE. THEN THE MAN CAME UP THE STEPS AND KNOCKED very softly, the way you knock when you know someone is sick.

Luis opened the door, and then he stood there with it open and could not say anything at all.

The man nodded to him and went past him into the front room. He took off the seed cap and held it. Glory was asleep, or near it, with her mouth open and her hands on top of the sheet. He went to the foot of the bed and lifted the sheet back from her feet, which were swollen, grey and cold. He took one of them in both his hands and began to rub it slowly, the heel, the arch, then each toe.

She opened her eyes.

Who is that?

It's Dean, Mama.

She lifted her head an inch off the pillow and looked at him down the length of the bed. His hair had gone grey since she had seen him. He had a three-day beard and a paper cup of gas station coffee balanced on the footboard.

What in the world are you doing here?

Come to see about you.

Honey. She let her head down. *It smells like a hog lot in here. You've got a bus with gold faucets in it and a house on the lake with a fountain in the yard. You don't need to be smelling this. Go on home. I've got my girls to do for me.*

I was in London, Dean Sackett said, and kept rubbing her foot. *At the Wembley show. Five called me at the hotel at four in the morning their time. I got on the first plane they had. Mama, I could smell how good you are from all the way across the ocean. That's why I came. I'll do for you.*

Luis went into the kitchen, where Danny was asleep with his head on the table, and woke him by the shoulder.

Dean Sackett is in the front room, he said, *rubbing Mama's feet.*

Shut up, said Danny. Then he went and looked. He came back and sat down at the table and did not say anything for a long time either.

• • •

Everybody in the country knew Dean Sackett. He had been on the Opry since 1959. He had eleven number ones, a duet with a woman whose name everyone knew, a Christmas special on the network, and a jacket. The jacket was famous by itself. It was white, cut in North Hollywood in 1971 by the same tailor shop that made the suits for the big stars, and it had so many rhinestones sewn into it that under the lights of the Ryman he seemed to be made of them, a man-shaped field of sparks. The fans called it the Thousand Eyes. On the cover of his greatest-hits album he stood in it with his arms out, and you could see the photographer in some of the stones.

He had not worn it in six years. Nobody in the business knew where it had gone.

He stayed three days. He slept in the recliner in the front room with his windbreaker over him. When Glory needed the pan, in the night or the day, he was up before anyone else could move. He did not let any of the girls touch it, or Marva either, and when Marva started to object he looked at her with such plain courtesy that she stopped. He slid it under her himself, gently, talking to her the whole time in a low voice about nothing, about the weather in London, about a dog he had had as a boy in Grundy County. He cleaned her with warm washcloths. Then he lifted the pan and carried it out of the room and down the hall to the bathroom, and the girls in the kitchen doorway watched him go by.

He carried it up in front of him, level, in both hands, the way a deacon carries the tray of the Lord's Supper down the aisle so that not one drop will spill in the cups. His face did not change. There was not a wrinkle on it. He might have been carrying a cake with the candles lit.

On the third evening the parasite let up a little, the way it sometimes did for a day or two. She kept down some broth. She slept four hours without waking. In the morning she was sitting up against the pillows with color in her face. He kissed her on the forehead, put on his seed cap, and went out to the rental car. They heard the gravel under the tires, then nothing.

III. The Kitchen

Bellevue · Friday

The girls sat around the kitchen table that afternoon with the coffee going cold and could not leave it alone.

Dean Sackett, Danny said. *Dean Sackett emptied that pan. With his own hands.*

Like it was perfume, said Luis. *Like it was a box of chocolates.*

Did you see his face? I couldn't do that with my face. I love her more than my own mother and I couldn't do that with my face.

That man has got a hundred people working for him, said Marva. *He has got people to carry his guitar. He has got people to carry his coffee from the bus to the stage.* She turned her cup around. *Three days. He wouldn't let me near her.*

He must love her, said Luis. *He must love her to death.*

Y'all come in here, Glory called from the front room. Her voice was stronger than it had been in a week. *I can hear every word you're saying.*

They came in and stood around the bed, and Marva sat on the edge of it, and Glory looked at them.

It isn't any wonder he loves me, she said. *Sit down. I'll tell you why.*

IV. The Question

The Satin Slipper, off Second Avenue · 1981

In the spring of 1981, she told them, Dean Sackett was dying. Not in his body. In the other way, the way the big stars die. He had not had a record in the top forty in three years. The young ones in hats were coming up behind him. At the Opry the flowers they sent to his dressing room wilted before the second show. The Thousand Eyes, which had been white, had gone a little yellow under the arms, and he sweated through it now under the lights in a way he never used to. The stones did not shine the way they had. He could not sit still. He would get up from a chair in the middle of a sentence and walk around the room. He had started waking at three in the morning in the house on the lake with his

HEART GOING LIKE A BIRD AGAINST A WINDOW, SURE HE WAS going to die, and he did not know whether he was afraid of dying or afraid that he was already dead. He had a doctor in Hendersonville and a preacher in Hendersonville and they did not help.

His banjo player was a skinny man from Sparta named Lonnie Pruitt, whom everybody called Five, for the five-string. Five had been playing behind him for nineteen years. Five was also one of Glory's, from way back, from the beer-joint days, though nobody in Dean's band knew that, and Five had sat in the dressing room at the Satin Slipper more Saturday nights than he had sat in church.

One night after a show at the Opry, Five told Dean he knew somebody who might help him. Dean asked who. Five said, a hairdresser. Dean looked at him a long time. Then he said he would go anywhere.

They came after closing, at two-thirty in the morning, in through the alley door off Second Avenue. Dean was still wearing the jacket under a raincoat, because he had not stopped to change. A dozen people were still in the club, the bartender, some of the girls, a few regulars finishing up. They all saw him. Nobody said a word. Glory was in her dressing room with the door shut, taking off her face.

Five did not knock. He got his banjo out of its case right there in the hall and sat down on an upturned beer crate outside her door and played. He played "Wildwood Flower," slow, the way the Carters did it, an old song about a girl, her ringlets, and the man who left her. Glory said afterward that she had never heard it played that tender, before or since, like a man singing about the one he loved and about his God at the same time and not able to tell the two apart. When he finished she opened the door.

She was in her robe with half her lashes off. She looked at Five on the beer crate and at Dean Sackett standing behind him in the hall in his raincoat with the stones showing at the collar, and she understood what was the matter with him the way she would have understood a bad perm.

Well, come in, honey, she said. *Ask me whatever you want. I'll answer you.*

He sat down on the little chair by her vanity, in the light of all those bulbs, and asked her the thing he had been asking himself at three in the morning.

Why is it everybody hates everybody? he said. *I don't mean bad people. I mean everybody. My wife and me. My band. Me and the boys coming up. Me and the boys that came up before me. Everybody wants to get along. Nobody wants to hate anybody. And we all end up hating each other anyhow. Why is that?*

She took off the other row of lashes and laid them on the vanity next to the first ones.

Jealous and stingy, she said. *That's all it ever is. Wanting what somebody else has got and holding on to what you've got. You show me two people hating each other and I'll show you one of those, or both.*

He sat there a while. Then he asked her where jealous and stingy came from, and she told him. He asked her where that came from, and she told him that too. They went on like that, question and answer, the whole rest of the night, with Five sitting on the beer crate in the hall with the banjo across his knees, and the bartender sweeping around him, and the dozen people in the club pretending to finish their drinks so they could listen. She said she couldn't remember half of what she said. She said it didn't feel like her saying it.

At six in the morning he stood up. She said he looked as if somebody had set something heavy down off him that he had been carrying since he was born. Then he took off the Thousand Eyes and laid it over the back of her chair.

I don't need that anymore, he said. *You keep it.*

He walked out the alley door in his shirtsleeves into the first light. The bartender, who had served him at a Christmas party on Music Row in 1974, swore to his dying day that the man who walked out that door was ten years younger than the one who had come in. Most of the girls who were there said the same. And it is a fact that Dean Sackett's next record came out the following spring with his face on the cover in a plain blue work shirt, and that it went to number one, and that people who held it next to the greatest-hits album could not make the arithmetic come out. He swore it was the same photographer and no airbrush. His hair, which had been going, had come back in. The fans started calling him Young Dean, the way they had in 1959, and the name stuck to him from then on.

Some of the dozen people in the club that night changed too. The bartender quit drinking. One of the regulars went home to Memphis and told his mother. Five went back on the road with Dean and played behind him six more years, and when Dean's wife found out about Five, from somebody who meant it as a weapon, Dean kept him in the band anyway and said so to anyone who asked.

So no, Glory said, in the front room in Bellevue, with the girls sitting around her on the bed and the floor, *it isn't any wonder he'd come. I helped him once when nobody else could. That's all that is.*

V. Company

The front room · Friday evening

SHE HAD THEM HELP HER UP HIGHER ON THE PILLOWS. THE light through the dogwood was going orange. She looked at each of them a while, Marva and Danny and Luis and the two others who had come in from work, the way she used to look at them in the dressing-room mirror before they went on, checking.

Listen to me now, she said. *I'm going to tell you this once and I want you to remember it when I'm not here to say it.*

They waited.

It's a good thing just to look at good people. You don't have to do anything. Just get where you can see them. And it's a better thing to live with them. You stay away from fools. I don't mean dumb, I mean fools. A fool will cost you twenty years and you won't even know you paid it. Living with a fool is like living with somebody who hates you. Living with somebody good is like coming home to your people. She smiled at them. *Your real people. The ones you get to pick.*

Then she asked them to sing. Not one of them would have known a hymn from a hole in the ground except Danny, who had been raised Free Will Baptist in Clay County, and Glory herself. But she started it, low, with no piano, the way they did it in Marshall County with the tuning fork, and Danny came in on the harmony, and after the first time through

the others had the words and came in too, ragged, in the front room in Bellevue with the window open.

> *Blest be the tie that binds*
> *Our hearts in Christian love;*
> *The fellowship of kindred minds*
> *Is like to that above.*
>
> *— John Fawcett, "Blest Be the Tie That Binds" (1782)*

When it was done she lay back.

Find you somebody good, she said, *and wise, and kind, and that does what they say they'll do, and go along with them. Go along with them the way the moon goes along with the stars.*

Luis asked her, because he was nineteen and had wanted to ask her since the day he came, why she called herself Glory.

She laughed, which made her cough.

Because when I was eight years old at the Lewisburg Church of Christ, she said, *the preacher read out a verse at a funeral and I thought it was the most beautiful thing anybody ever wrote. I thought it was written about me. I still do.* And she said it for him, the whole verse, without a mistake.

> *There is one glory of the sun, and another glory of the moon, and another glory of the stars; for one star differeth from another star in glory.*
>
> *— 1 Corinthians 15:41*

Now go get me the jacket, she said.

• • •

Marva went to the back bedroom and found it at the far end of the closet, in a dry cleaner's bag behind the white fox, where it had hung for six years. She took it out of the bag and brought it to the front room. Glory had worn it in her act at the Satin Slipper exactly once, on the night after Dean gave it to her, and then she had put it away, because it was not hers and she had known that.

Glory looked at it.

Hang it on the door where I can see it, she said.

So Marva hung it on a hanger over the top of the open door to the hall, facing the bed, and turned on the little lamp on the dresser, because it was getting dark. It was still white, mostly. The underarms were still a little yellow. The stones were still in it, every one; somebody in North Hollywood had sewn them to last. Each stone took the small light of the lamp and held it. Each held the window with the dogwood going dark beyond it, the bed, the faces of the girls around the bed, and the faces of the girls in all the other stones, so that the whole jacket hung there in the doorway giving back the room a thousand times over, every piece of it shining in every other piece. Glory lay and looked at it until she fell asleep.

Background

The verses

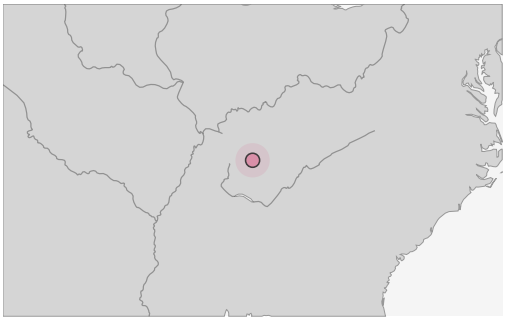
> *The sight of the elect (Arya) is good, to live with them is always happiness; if a man does not see fools, he will be truly happy.*
>
> Dhammapada 206, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who walks in the company of fools suffers a long way; company with fools, as with an enemy, is always painful; company with the wise is pleasure, like meeting with kinsfolk.*
>
> Dhammapada 207, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Therefore, one ought to follow the wise, the intelligent, the learned, the much enduring, the dutiful, the elect; one ought to follow a good and wise man, as the moon follows the path of the stars.*
>
> Dhammapada 208, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha lies ill with dysentery near the end of his life at the village of Beḷuva. Sakka, king of the gods, lays aside his immense heavenly body and comes to rub the Buddha's feet. The Buddha tells him that to the gods the smell of human beings is like carrion and sends him away, but Sakka answers that he smelled the fragrance of the Buddha's goodness from 84,000 leagues off. He lets no one else touch the vessel of excrement, and carries it out on his head as if it held perfume,

without a flicker of disgust. When the monks marvel, the Buddha explains that Sakka once came to him in terror of death, led by the celestial musician Pañcasikha, who played at the cave entrance; the Buddha invited him to ask any question, answered him, and Sakka was transformed from Old Sakka into Young Sakka. Sakka's first question, in the Sakkapañha Sutta, is why beings who wish to live without hatred live in hatred, and the answer is envy and avarice. Read the full commentary story, or about Sakka, the Buddhist form of Indra, whom Indian tradition calls the thousand-eyed.



Bellevue (Nashville), Tennessee

Nashville, 1987

Nashville's gay bars were where the city's first response to AIDS took shape. Warehouse 28, a dance club opened in 1978, held drag shows and auctions whose proceeds helped found Nashville CARES in 1985; its co-owner Steve Smith, a co-founder of CARES, died of AIDS in 1995. A regular there remembered going to two funerals a week, and sometimes three, in the worst years. Before effective treatment, intestinal infections such as cryptosporidiosis, which pass in a few weeks in a healthy person, could cause relentless diarrhea and wasting in people with AIDS. Fear of contagion was widespread, and some hospital staff in those years would not enter patients' rooms.

Country music in the early 1980s was being remade by the *Urban Cowboy* boom and a younger generation of singers, and the established stars of the Grand Ole Opry, which had moved from the Ryman Auditorium to Opryland in 1974, felt it. The rhinestone stage suits of the era came from North Hollywood, from the shop of Nudie Cohn and his tailors. Every spring from 1969 to 1991 the promoter Mervyn Conn brought Nashville acts to London for the International Festival of Country Music at Wembley. Dean Sackett, Glory Darlene and the Satin Slipper are fictional.

After the story of Sakka's attendance from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 206–208). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901) and John Fawcett's hymn "Blest Be the Tie That Binds" (1782). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 16

Pleasure

16.1

Empty-Handed

> *So long as a man clingeth unto the elements and fragments of this world … and holdeth converse with them … he is deceived and blinded.*
> — *Theologia Germanica XIX*

Zo heb ik het gehoord, on the Bohemia River.

I. The Stoep

Midwout (Flatbush), Long Island · spring 1702

Teunis Joosten was a cooper at Midwout, and he and his wife Marritje had buried four children in the churchyard there and kept one. The one was Joost, seventeen, who could already raise a tight barrel and who had never in his life been out of sight of both of them at once.

In April two men came up from the Bohemia River in Maryland to sell linen thread in New York, and a neighbor who had dealings with them asked Teunis to give them a bed. They were brethren of the Labadie house on the Manor, plain men in coarse cloth. Marritje fed them. When they had eaten, the older one took off his hat and sat. After a while the younger took off his. Neither said a word for half a quarter of an hour, and the family, not knowing what was wanted, sat too. Then the older man put his hat on and said a few words to the table, low, as if they were for the bread. He said that everyone under this roof had been lent to the others for a little while, that the Lender was good, and that a heart could be set where nothing was ever called back.

Teunis thought it a long grace for after supper. Marritje thought they looked underfed. Joost did not sleep, and in the morning, when the two men had gone down to the ferry, he asked leave to follow them and go in.

No, said his father.

They put the men on one side and the women on the other, said his mother. *They take your goods and your name. Old Herrman's son went in to them and left his wife, and his father cursed him for it, and he was dead inside two years.*

Joost said no more about it, which frightened them worse than if he had argued. After that, whenever Teunis went to the shop he said to Marritje, *Keep him where you can see him,* and whenever Marritje went to a neighbor's she walked the boy to the shop door and said the same to Teunis.

On a morning in May Teunis had staves to buy at the landing. Marritje said to herself that she would keep the boy, and keep him well. The house had a back door that had been nailed up since the winter and a front door that gave on the stoep. She sat down in the front door, on the sill itself, set one foot against one doorpost and the other foot against the other, took up her distaff and began to spin.

Joost stood behind her a while watching the spindle drop and climb.

Moeder. Draw your foot back a little. I have to go out to the necessary.

She drew her foot back. He stepped over her thread and went around the corner of the house. She set her foot against the post again and spun perhaps two ells before it came to her that the necessary was on the other side.

II. Gone In

Bohemia Manor, Cecil County, Maryland · summer 1702

Where is he? Teunis said, with the staves still on his shoulder.

He was here but a moment ago.

He looked in the loft and the shop and the church. Then he said, *The Manor,* and he found a sloop bound for the South River, and at New Castle he took the cart road that old Herrman had cut across to the Bohemia, twenty miles through oak woods, on foot.

The Labadie house stood on a neck of good land above the river, a great plain dwelling with its barns, and around it the plantation: corn,

flax and hemp, cattle, and tobacco. The tobacco was worked by Africans the house had bought. The two brethren who had first come spying out the country had written down their horror of that trade, and of tobacco too, and their house now did both.

He found his son in a row of men pulling flax, in the coarse dress of the house, with his own good coat gone into the common chest. Teunis stood at the end of the row and wept like a child. *Joost. Joost, why do you undo me?*

The boy went red to the ears and went on pulling. Nobody stopped work. Teunis wept until he was done, and sat down on the headland, and looked at his son's back going away from him up the row. After a time a thought came to him that he had not expected.

With the boy in there, what is a cooper at Midwout? Who am I hooping casks for?

He went up to the house that same day and asked to be received. The rule was known to everyone on the river. Whoever came in, rich or poor, put what he had into the common stock, and whoever afterward had a mind to leave must leave what he had brought and go out empty-handed. Teunis signed over the shop, the tools and the house at Midwout by a letter carried north with the next skipper. They gave him the cooper's shed, where the hogsheads for the tobacco were made, and a place on the men's side.

Marritje waited at Midwout. A week went by, and another. Then a stranger came with a paper and looked at her house the way a man looks at a house he means to buy, and she understood where both of them were.

With my son gone in and my husband gone in, she said to the stranger, who had not asked, *what would I keep a door for?*

She took the distaff, since nobody had bought that, and went south, and was received on the women's side.

III. The Retting Pond

The same · August and September

THEY WERE UPWARDS OF A HUNDRED IN THAT FAMILY, MEN, women and children. The men ate at one long table and the women at another, in a different room. An English Friend who was given supper with the men about that time wrote down how it went: when the food was in, one man pulled off his hat, and after a space another, and so on down the benches until all sat bare-headed and silent, each praying when he was moved to and not before, and then the hats went back on one by one and each man fell to eating without regard for those still uncovered. The children were taught together under a tutor. It was told of the house in its first years that a mother who kissed her own child there had been rebuked for showing so naturally her fleshly cleavings, and that the cells had been kept without fire in winter while wood was burned in the fields to be rid of it. Some of that had slackened. The tables had not.

For three days Teunis, Marritje and Joost kept the order of the house. On the fourth, at the hour after the noon meal when a brother might walk by himself and examine his heart, the three of them walked by themselves to the same place.

The place was the bank of the retting pond. The pulled flax lay sunk there in bundles under stones, rotting loose from its own straw, and the stink of it carried to the tobacco barns, so that nobody in the house went near the pond who was not sent. They sat down on the bank in a row with Marritje in the middle and they talked. They talked about who had bought the house at Midwout and whether he would keep the pear tree. About the dominie's wife. About whether the gray cloth itched Joost as it itched his father, and whether he had enough at the men's table, where his mother could not see his plate, and whether that cough was the flax dust or something on his chest. Marritje took his head in her two hands and kissed him on the hair, there in the open, and looked him over for ticks.

They were there the next day at the same hour, and at dusk too, and after that at every hour that was not counted. When they were set to work

in three different places they found errands that crossed. Teunis would look down the men's bench at supper to see whether the boy had bread, and so his hat was always the last one off.

The house could not bear it. Some were angry for the rule's sake. But there were women at the sisters' table who had left husbands in Amsterdam to come out of the world, and men who had not been let to carry their own children across the yard, and they had made what peace they could with that, and now three people sat on the pond bank every afternoon holding on to each other as if nobody had ever asked them for anything. A widow from Friesland, with two sons dead in the colony at Surinam, stopped eating.

Pieter Sluyter had the rule of the house, and by then the best of its land in his own name, and most complaints went up to him. This one the brethren and sisters carried to old Geertje Wybes instead. It was not a matter that mortifying would mend, and they knew it.

IV. The Cell

The sisters' side · an evening in September

Geertje Wybes was past seventy. As a young wife in Amsterdam she had heard Jean de Labadie preach, and she had followed his people to Herford and Altona and at last to the castle at Wieuwerd in Friesland, where she kept the sickroom of Juffrouw van Schurman, the most learned woman in Europe, until that lady died. Then she had crossed the ocean with the first company. It was said in the house that the Father's hearth was never cold. Hers had never been lit, and nobody had told her to keep it so. She spun flax all day by the one window and owned the stool she sat on only in the sense that no one else wanted it.

She sent for the three of them. They stood in her cell in a row.

They tell me you sit on the pond bank every day and talk, the three of you. Is it true?

It is true, moeder, said Teunis.

Why do you do it? It is not the way of people who have come out.

Teunis turned his hat around in his hands.

We had five. Four are in the churchyard at Midwout. This one we counted every night of his life, before the candle was put out, the way you count the one coin you have. Moeder Geertje, we cannot live apart. We would keep your rule. We do not know how to be where we cannot see him.

Nor he us, Marritje said. Joost looked at the floor and did not say she was wrong.

The old woman let the wheel run down.

I left a husband in Amsterdam in the year 'sixty-nine, because he would not come, and a girl of nine with him. I have not seen either one since. I know what it is not to see them. I know it this evening. And I have sat thirty years at a table with women I would not have chosen for neighbors, and to have to look at those is a pain as well. It took me a long time to find out that it is the same nail. Whether you must look or cannot look, the heart is hung on a creature, and it tears when the creature moves, and they all move.

She had one book besides the Scriptures, the little *German Theology* in a Dutch printing with the boards gone, which had come with her from Amsterdam to Herford and from Friesland over the sea. She found the place without her spectacles. It was where the book takes up the hard saying about hating father and mother.

> *He meaneth it thus: "He who doth not forsake and part with everything, can never know My eternal truth, nor attain unto My life."*
>
> *But so long as a man clingeth unto the elements and fragments of this world (and above all to himself), and holdeth converse with them, and maketh great account of them, he is deceived and blinded, and perceiveth what is good no further than as it is most convenient and pleasant to himself and profitable to his own ends.*
>
> *— Theologia Germanica XIX*

Elements and fragments, she said. *A husband is one. A girl of nine is one. That is all I have to tell you.* And she set the wheel going.

In that house anyone moved to it might speak at the evening exercise. Geertje Wybes almost never did. That night she stood up among the sisters and said to the whole family what she had said in the cell, the hus-

band and the girl of nine and the table and the nail, and read the passage out. It is told that the widow from Friesland ate her supper afterward, and that a good many in the room, who had given up as much as she had and had only gritted their teeth over it, dated their peace from that evening.

V. The Cart Road

The road to New Castle · the next morning

THE THREE SAT ON THE POND BANK ONE MORE TIME, BEFORE light, and nobody had to say much.

She is right, Teunis said. *I heard it and I knew she was right. And at supper I was looking down the bench again to see had he got bread.*

I watched her spin, said Marritje. *She has a daughter somewhere who is past forty and she does not know if the girl has a tooth in her head. I could not do it. I do not want to be able to do it.*

Joost had been in the house four months. He looked a long time at the row of men going out to the hemp with their hoes on their shoulders, not one of them turning his head to see who was beside him. Then he looked at his mother's hands.

Nor I, he said. *Not yet.*

They went up and told the house they were leaving. The rule held for going as it had for coming. The shop at Midwout, the tools, the money from the house and forty years of barrels stayed in the common stock. They were given back the clothes they had walked in with. Marritje asked for her distaff, and was told it had been put to use on the sisters' side, and she let it go.

Geertje Wybes did not come to the door. She had flax on the wheel.

They went down old Herrman's road toward New Castle with nothing to carry, three abreast where the track was wide enough, Marritje in the middle with a hand in each of theirs. Walking that way, the three of them had only two empty hands among them, the two on the outside.

Background

The verses

> *He who gives himself to vanity, and does not give himself to meditation, forgetting the real aim (of life) and grasping at pleasure, will in time envy him who has exerted himself in meditation.*
>
> Dhammapada 209, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Let no man ever look for what is pleasant, or what is unpleasant. Not to see what is pleasant is pain, and it is pain to see what is unpleasant.*
>
> Dhammapada 210, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Let, therefore, no man love anything; loss of the beloved is evil. Those who love nothing and hate nothing, have no fetters.*
>
> Dhammapada 211, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the only son of a household at Sāvatthī hears monks give thanks after a meal and wants to go forth. His parents refuse and guard him by turns. One day his mother sits in the doorway spinning, a foot against each doorpost; he asks her to move her foot so he can relieve himself, and runs to the monastery. His father follows, weeps, and becomes a monk himself. His mother follows and becomes a nun. But the three cannot stay apart, and spend their days sitting and talking together, until the monks and nuns complain. The Buddha tells them this is not how those who have gone forth should live, and speaks the three verses. Many who hear them are helped. The three, saying they cannot live without each other, go back to the household life. Read the full commentary story.

Bohemia Manor, Maryland

Bohemia Manor, 1702

The Labadists were followers of Jean de Labadie, a former Jesuit turned Reformed preacher, who gathered a community of the "elect" that held all goods in common and lived apart from the world. Its best-known member was the scholar Anna Maria van Schurman, who died in the mother house at Wieuwerd in Friesland in 1678. In 1683 two envoys, Peter Sluyter and Jasper Danckaerts, obtained some 3,750 acres of Augustine Herrman's Bohemia Manor in Cecil County, Maryland, and founded a daughter colony that grew to a little over a hundred people, many of them Dutch converts from New York. Members surrendered their property on entering and left empty-handed; men and women ate at separate tables; marriage and parenthood were subordinated to the house. The supper with the hats is described by the English Quaker minister Samuel Bownas, who visited in the first years of the 1700s. The rebuke for "fleshly cleavings" and the fireless cells come from a hostile former member, Peter Dittelbach, writing in 1692. Both are quoted in Bartlett B. James, The Labadist Colony in Maryland (1899).

Danckaerts's journal of 1679–80 condemns both tobacco and slavery, but the Maryland house grew tobacco with enslaved African labor. In 1698 Sluyter divided most of the tract among the leading members and kept a neck of land for himself; he died wealthy in 1722, and within a few years the community was gone. The cooper's family and Geertje Wybes are invented. The Theologia Germanica, an anonymous German treatise of the fourteenth century that Luther sent to the press, was read by Protestant pietists for centuries afterward; it is quoted here in Susanna Winkworth's English of 1854.

After the story of the three who went forth from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 209–211). The original. Scripture from the Theologia Germanica, translated by Susanna Winkworth (1854). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

16.2

The Potato Ground

> *For he alone loses none dear to him, to whom all are dear in Him who cannot be lost.*
> *— Augustine, Confessions IV*

Voilà comme on me l'a conté, in the Belgian settlement.

I. The Ground

Door County, Wisconsin · October and November 1871

All that summer everybody burned. There had been next to no snow in the winter and next to no rain since, and a man with forty acres of maple and hemlock standing between himself and a crop did what he did every year. He rolled the logs into heaps of twenty and thirty, set them alight, and let them go for days. The railroad gangs burned their slash and the mills burned their edgings. By September the smoke lay so thick on Green Bay that the boats steered by compass at noon, and ash came down on the washing, and nobody stopped, because wheat does not grow under trees.

Lambert Colignon burned his heaps with the rest. He had come out from the commune of Grez in Brabant in 1856 with a wife and a boy in arms, had paid a dollar and a quarter an acre, and in fifteen years had got eleven acres clear, a hewn-log house, and a yoke of oxen. The boy in arms was Jules, seventeen now. In the spring Lambert had sent him four miles north to Williamson's shingle mill, because the mill paid in money and the farm did not.

On Sunday night the eighth of October the wind got up out of the southwest, and all the little fires became one fire. It came through the Belgian settlement faster than a horse can run. Lambert and his wife

Octavie lay in the mud of the cattle hole with a wet ox blanket over them. When they stood up there was no house and no barn, and one ox.

At the mill there had been seventy-seven people. When the fire came, a good half of them ran for the potato patch, which was the only open ground, and lay down between the rows on their faces, thinking fire cannot cross dirt. It did not cross. It went over. Thirty-five died there in the rows. Others died elsewhere about the place. Seven men went down the well and five came up. When it was all counted, seventeen were living out of seventy-seven, and Jules Colignon was not one of them, and nobody could tell Lambert which of those in the patch had been his.

So he went to the ground. Every morning he walked the four miles north through standing black poles without a leaf on them, in ash to the ankle, and after the rains in a gray mud. He stood at the edge of the potato patch, where the rows still showed, baked hard as brick, and he wept there, and at dusk he walked back. He did it through October and into November.

He did not eat what Octavie set in front of him. He had not cut one log toward a roof, and the snow was coming. They slept under charred boards leaned against the root-cellar bank. Relief was coming down the bay on tugs to Dyckesville, flour and pork and blankets and axes, sent from Milwaukee and from places nobody in the settlement had heard of. It was Octavie who walked there for their order and carried the flour home. It was Octavie who took the axe to where the neighbors were raising one another's shanties, a day at each place, and gave their day. She came back at night and said nothing to him. There was nothing to say to his back.

II. The Reader

The Colignon clearing · a morning of wet snow

In the years when a priest reached the settlement four times in twelve months, the people chose one of their own to read the prayers of the Mass and the Gospel of the Sunday aloud in somebody's house. The one they chose was Hubert Bodart, because he had had two

YEARS AT THE LITTLE SEMINARY AT FLOREFFE BEFORE HIS father died and the farm called him home. He was near seventy now and a shingle shaver, with the callus of the drawknife across both palms. He also wrote what needed writing. He had written the settlement's letters home for twenty years, and now he was writing its lists for the relief, house by house: what was burned, and who.

His own house was gone like everybody's. He had carried two books out of it inside his shirt and had lain on them in a plowed field.

He came up the Colignon track before Lambert had set out. Lambert saw him and thought, *He wants the boy's name and age for his paper. And he will say what one says.* He turned the washtub over for the old man, since it was the one seat they had, and stood.

Hubert sat down. He did not take out his paper.

Lambert. Why are you sad?

Lambert looked at him. The country was black from Sturgeon Bay to the Red River road. It was a question for a simpleton.

My son is dead. That is why I am sad.

Yes, Hubert said. *And Désiré Gaspard's two girls. And the Williamsons, nearly to the last one. And at Rosière, and across the water at Peshtigo more than anybody has been able to count. I have the lists here in my coat, Lambert. There is not a clearing between the Bay Settlement and Little Sturgeon where the table is not short. It did not come to your door and pass the others. What could die has died. What could burn has burned.*

That is a thing to say to a man.

It is what my grandmother's people said. They did not go on as you are doing.

What people? When was this?

Sit down on the ground and I will tell you.

III. The Essart

The hills above the Meuse · in the old time

ABOVE THE MEUSE, TOWARD THE ARDENNE, THE SOIL ON THE hilltops is thin and sour, and the people there worked it this way. Every eighteen or twenty years they cut the broom and scrub oak off a piece of

THE HILL, LET IT DRY WHERE IT FELL, BURNED IT ON THE SPOT and sowed rye in the warm ash. A piece of hill so burned they called an essart. It gave one crop of rye and then went back to broom.

There was a man there named Bastin, who had a wife, a son, a daughter, the son's young wife and a servant girl, so that they were six at table. Bastin had one saying, and the five had heard it since they could hear. *Everything lent is called for.* He said it over the soup and at sowing. *You are lent, I am lent, the cow is lent. Be good to what is lent and do not be astonished when it is called for.* He made them say it back to him. They came to think of it every day of their lives, the way people think of the weather.

One spring Bastin and his son went up to burn their essart. The son raked the dry broom into rows and fired it. At the edge of the piece was a heap of field stones with an adder in it, and the smoke got into her eyes. She came out in a fury and struck the first thing she met, which was the boy's ankle. He took four steps and sat down and died.

Bastin set down his fork and came and saw what it was. He carried his son into the shade of a thorn tree, laid him straight, and covered his face with his own smock. *What was lent has been called for,* he said. Then he went back to the fire, because a burn that is left alone takes the hill.

A neighbor came along the path below. *Are you going down?* Bastin called. *Then stop at my door and tell my wife this. Today she is to send dinner for one and not for two. And the girl is not to bring it alone. Let all four come, in clean linen, and bring the sprigs of box from behind the crucifix.*

The neighbor said it at the door just so. *Who gave you this message?* the wife asked. *Bastin.* Then she knew. She did not cry out. She said to the other three, *What was lent has been called for. Wash your hands.* They went up the hill in white caps with dinner for one and the blessed box. Bastin sat down by the thorn tree and ate, because the afternoon's work was still in front of him. Then they dug, the five of them, at the edge of the essart, and laid the box sprigs on him, and filled it in. Not one of them wept.

Now in those days the Good God went about on the roads more than He does at present, looking like anybody. An old man with a stick stopped at the edge of the burn.

What are you putting in the ground there? A dog?

A man, said Bastin.

Some enemy of yours, then, that you bury him so dry.

Our own son.

Then he was no great loss.

He was the best we had.

Then why does nobody weep?

Bastin said, *An adder leaves her old skin on the heath and goes on her way. What is under this thorn is the skin. It does not feel the spade and it does not hear crying. He has gone where he was going.*

The mother said, *He came to me without my sending for him, and he has left without asking my leave. He went as he came. What is there for me to say about it?*

The sister said, *If I cried I would grow thin and ugly, and whom would that help? My mother would have two sorrows to look at.*

The young wife said, *A child cries for the moon in the pond. I am not a child.*

The servant girl said, *When a crock is broken you do not sit down beside the pieces.*

The old man said, *You have answered well. Go home.* And he went on up the hill. In the morning the essart was green. Rye that no hand had sown stood four fingers high in ash that was still warm, in every corner of the burn except a place the size of a door under the thorn tree.

IV. The Book

The Colignon clearing · the same morning

THEY WERE MADE OF WOOD, LAMBERT SAID.

I said the same to my grandmother. She hit me with the spoon.

And you, Hubert? In the sickness year you buried Ferdinande and two of the children in one week. I helped carry. You howled like a dog on the road.

I did. I am not Bastin. I did not walk up here to tell you I am Bastin. The old man looked at the lean-to, the cold ashes, the axe with rust starting on it. *But see what you do. You have put down your work. You do not eat. Your wife raises other men's walls alone and sleeps under burnt boards. And every day you*

go and stand in that field as if he were kept there. He is not kept there, Lambert. Bastin at least knew where his son was not.

He took out the smaller of his two books.

This is a bishop in Africa, fourteen hundred years ago. When he was young the friend of his heart died of a fever, and he went about just as you do. He hated every place because the friend was not in it. He wondered that other people had the face to go on living. Afterward he worked out what had happened to him.

He read it out slowly, putting it into Walloon as he went.

> *For whence had that former grief so easily reached my very inmost soul, but that I had poured out my soul upon the dust, in loving one that must die, as if he would never die?*
>
> *Blessed whoso loveth Thee, and his friend in Thee, and his enemy for Thee. For he alone loses none dear to him, to whom all are dear in Him who cannot be lost.*
>
> *— Augustine, Confessions IV*

Was I not to love him, then?

He does not say that. He says you loved him as if he could not die. You held him the way a man holds water in his fist, and the grief is the size of the fist. The fear was too. You had that long before any fire. Every time the boy was late on the road, you had it. Is it so?

Lambert did not answer, and that was an answer.

Love him where he cannot be lost. That is all the man says. I have read it thirty years and I can do it perhaps one day in ten. Hubert put the book back in his shirt and took out the paper and a pencil. *Now give me his name.*

Jules-Joseph Colignon. Seventeen years. Shingle packer at Williamson's.

Hubert wrote it at the foot of the sheet. Lambert watched him write, and saw how far down the sheet the pencil had to go to find a place, and that there was a second sheet under it, and a third.

When the old man had gone down the track, Lambert ate what was in the pot, standing up, all of it. Then he took the axe and went to find Octavie.

V. June

Door County · 1872

They had a roof by Christmas, of relief boards. In the spring there was nothing to clear. The fire had done in one night what Lambert would have done in thirty years, and he put the one ox beside a borrowed one and sowed wheat in the ash between the black stumps, on more ground than he had ever had open. Everybody in the settlement did the same. Nobody called it a gift.

In June he walked north once more, the first time since the snow. Nothing had been built at Williamson's and nothing would be. The potato patch had come up. Not all of it. But here and there along the baked ridges, where a tuber had lain deep enough when the fire went over, dark green tops stood out of the ground, and a few were in flower. Nobody had planted them and nobody was going to dig them.

He stood at the edge for a time. He did not weep, which surprised him, and then did not surprise him. He said the boy's name once, aloud.

Then, having no hoe with him, he went down the nearest row on his knees and drew the earth up around each plant with his hands, the way they are hilled. When he had done the one row he got up and went home to his own.

Background

The verse

> *From pleasure comes grief, from pleasure comes fear; he who is free from pleasure knows neither grief nor fear.*
>
> Dhammapada 212, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Müller's "pleasure" renders the Pāli *piya*, what is dear or beloved. In the commentary, a householder who has lost his son goes every day to the burning ground and weeps. The Buddha comes to his house and asks why he is sad, tells him that death is not confined to one place or one person, and relates the Uraga Jātaka: a farmer whose son is killed by a snake while burning rubbish in the field sends home for dinner for one instead of two, and the whole family burns the body without a tear. Sakka, king

of the gods, comes down to ask each of them why they do not weep, hears their answers (the cast-off snakeskin, the guest who came unbidden, the child crying for the moon, the broken pot) and fills their house with treasure. The Buddha then tells the father that grief and fear arise only from what is dear. Read the full commentary story.

Door County, Wisconsin

The Belgian settlement, 1871

From 1853 several thousand Walloon-speaking Belgians, many from around Grez-Doiceau in Brabant, took up government land at $1.25 an acre in Brown, Kewaunee and Door counties, Wisconsin. They cleared it by rolling logs into heaps and burning them, shaved shingles by hand for cash, and, with priests scarce, chose one of their own number to read the Mass prayers and the Sunday Gospel. After a rainless summer, the fires of land-clearing, logging and railroad building ran together on the night of October 8, 1871. The Peshtigo fire west of Green Bay killed well over a thousand people, more than any other fire in American history; a separate firestorm the same night burned a strip some sixty miles long through the Belgian settlements east of the bay. At the shingle-mill hamlet of Williamsonville, about sixty of seventy-seven residents died, thirty-five of them in the potato patch where they had taken refuge; five of seven men who went down the well survived. The place was never rebuilt and is now Tornado Memorial County Park.

Relief was landed from tugs at Dyckesville and carried inland, and it kept coming for eighteen months. The burned timberland became farmland, and the peninsula turned from lumber to wheat and dairying. To the south, near Green Bay, people who had sheltered through the night at Adele Brise's chapel at Robinsonville found its grounds untouched; it is now the National Shrine of Our Lady of Champion. Essartage, the cutting and burning of broom and coppice to sow rye in the ash, was practiced in the Belgian Ardennes into the nineteenth century. The Colignons and Hubert Bodart are invented. The Confessions are quoted in E. B. Pusey's English of 1838.

After the story of a certain head of a family from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 212). The original. Scripture from the Confessions of St. Augustine, translated by E. B. Pusey (1838). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

16.3

Eleven a Day

> *For no one is solicitous or anxious about anything, unless he loves it.*
> *— Spinoza, Ethics V, Prop. 20, note*

The way it was told to me, on Winesap Court.

I. The Prophet's Chamber

Holmdel, New Jersey · 1959–1966

Ray Conover's people had grown apples on the rise above Holmdel Road for a hundred and forty years, and in 1959, the year the telephone company began building on the potato fields across Crawfords Corner Road, Ray sold the orchard to a builder from Matawan and kept the house. The builder took out the Winesaps and the Staymans and put in nine split-levels around a circle of new asphalt, and named the circle after what he had cut down. The Conover house stood at the head of it, white clapboard, a century older than anything else on the street, with a horse chestnut in the yard and a back bedroom over the kitchen that Edith Conover called the prophet's chamber.

She had the name from Second Kings, from the woman of Shunem who told her husband to build a little room on the wall for the man of God, with a bed in it and a table and a stool and a candlestick, so that he would have a place to turn in when he passed. Edith had a spool bed, a maple dresser, a cane-bottomed chair and a reading lamp, and a guest book on the dresser with eighty-one names in it by 1966: missionaries home on furlough from the Congo and Assam and the Philippines, a Telugu pastor, two Karen schoolteachers, a deaf evangelist from Ohio who preached with his hands at the Baptist church on Holmdel Road

while his wife said it out loud beside him. On the dresser stood a round lacquer box from Pagan, red and black, with a peacock on the lid in gold leaf, which Mrs. Mabry of the Kachin Hills had given her in 1951, the first year the Mabrys slept in that room. Ray used to say she ran a hotel that never sent a bill. Ray died in 1962, and she went on running it.

The street was full of telephone people. The men drove out every morning to the new Bell Laboratories, a building a fifth of a mile long set down in the old potato fields, black glass that was turning, panel by panel, into mirror, so that on clear days it was mostly sky. There was a long pond in front of it, and a water tower on three white legs that the children said looked like a transistor. Whatever the men did in there, they did not talk about it at supper. The men who did not work for the telephone company drove to the station in Middletown and took the Long Branch train to Newark.

The only woman on Winesap Court who drove to the Laboratories herself was Mrs. Lotte Seligman, in the split-level across the circle from Edith's front door. She had come from Göttingen in 1936 with a doctorate in mathematics and one suitcase, and had added up death rates for an insurance company on Madison Avenue until the war, when the telephone company found her. She worked on what she called traffic, which had nothing to do with cars. She could tell you how many people in Monmouth County would pick up a telephone between ten and eleven on a Monday morning, and how many lines the exchange needed so that nine hundred and ninety-nine of them would hear a dial tone. A Dane named Erlang had worked it out for the city of Copenhagen in 1909, she said, and it was the same arithmetic as rain on a roof or burials in a parish. Nobody arranges them. They come anyway, at a rate.

Edith took her supper on Tuesdays and Fridays, because Mr. Seligman had died in 1958 and Lotte, left to herself, ate sardines on crackers standing at the sink. In return Lotte did Edith's taxes, and told her what the bank was doing with her money, and was the one Edith asked about anything that had a number in it. She was also the one Edith asked about the rest. Lotte said very little, and what she said, Edith found, kept. On the bookshelf in Lotte's living room there was a photograph of a man in a

wing collar and two girls in white dresses on a park bench, and the letters from Kassel had stopped in 1942. Edith had never asked, and Lotte had never said.

Edith's granddaughter Dorothy, her son Glenn's girl, had been coming up the hill to help with the prophet's chamber since she was eleven. She turned the mattress for every new guest and ironed the pillowcases with a sprinkle bottle. She learned to make tea the way the Assam people liked it, boiled in the milk with the sugar already in, and at fourteen she could set a table for a Telugu pastor and a deaf evangelist and know without being told which of them wanted the salt. Everybody called her Dorrie. She worked Saturdays at the notions counter in the Bamberger's at the Monmouth Shopping Center and was saving for Douglass College.

In February of 1966 Edith's sister in St. Petersburg broke her hip, and Edith went down on the train for six weeks, and that was the winter the government of Burma sent the missionaries home. The Mabrys had been thirty-one years in the Kachin Hills. They came to Winesap Court in the first week of March with two suitcases and a typewriter, and they found the prophet's chamber made up, the bed turned down, and Dorrie, sixteen years old, keeping the house.

She drove them in her father's Rambler to every church that wanted to hear them, as far as Trenton. She typed Mr. Mabry's letters to the Board at Valley Forge with two fingers. She made the tea boiled in milk. One morning Mrs. Mabry began to cry at the breakfast table because she would never see Myitkyina again, and Dorrie did not say anything at all; she reached across and held the old woman's hand and let her own eggs go cold. When Edith came home in April she found a new line in the guest book under the Mabrys' names, in Mrs. Mabry's small slanted hand. *Kept by Dorothy. Faithful and true.*

II. Route 35

October 1966

On the twenty-second of October, a Saturday, it rained from morning on. Dorrie closed out her register at half past nine and

drove north on Route 35 in the Rambler, and a southbound car crossed the center line. She died in the hospital in Red Bank a little after midnight, with Glenn and her mother beside the bed and Edith in the corridor on a plastic chair, holding her pocketbook on her knees with both hands.

Edith did everything. That was what she was for. She called the pastor and the funeral director and the florist. She chose the casket, and the blue dress from Easter, and the hymns. She sat on the edge of the bed with Glenn's wife, who could not hold a pencil, and made the list of who had to be called and called them. She set the women to work in the fellowship hall, and saw that the big urn was filled and the egg salad made and the folding chairs put out in rows. The Mabrys came up on the train from Philadelphia. Lotte Seligman came in a black hat and sat in the last pew, and stood when the others stood, and did not sing.

Then it was done. The chairs were stacked against the wall, the urn was rinsed and turned upside down on the drainboard, and Edith went home to the house at the head of the circle and found that she could not stop.

She cried in the A&P in front of the canned peaches. She cried in the car in the church lot on Thursday night and drove home without going in to choir. She stripped the bed in the prophet's chamber and made it up again and stripped it again. She did not sleep in her own bed; she slept in her clothes on the davenport with the radio on low. One night in the second week of November, a little before eleven, she looked out and saw that the kitchen light was on across the circle, and she put her coat on over her nightgown and went across the wet asphalt in her slippers.

III. Eleven

Winesap Court · November 1966

Lotte was at the kitchen table with a pad of green engineering paper and a slide rule and a cup of coffee gone cold, working. She did not seem surprised. She moved the pad over to make room, and

EDITH SAT DOWN, NOT ACROSS FROM HER BUT A LITTLE TO ONE side, the way you sit in a doctor's office, and put her face in her hands.

Lotte let her cry for some time. Then she said, *Edith. Why are you sitting in my kitchen in your nightgown, crying like this?*

So Edith told her. She said what she had not said to anybody, not to Glenn, not to the pastor: that the girl had been dearer to her than her own son. That she was faithful and true. That every missionary on every boat in the world could come through the prophet's chamber, and she would never see the like of her again.

Lotte listened to all of it. Then she turned the green pad around and picked up her pencil.

How many people live in Monmouth County?

I've heard you say. Four hundred thousand.

Four hundred and twenty, now. Lotte wrote it at the top of the page. *Suppose every one of them was as dear to you as Dorrie. Every one. Would you like that?*

Edith thought of the Mabrys, and the Telugu pastor, and the deaf man preaching with his hands. It was what she had wanted her whole life. It was what the room was for.

Yes, she said.

And how many die in Monmouth County every day?

I don't know. A great many.

Lotte worked it on the pad, saying it as she went, the way she must have said things for thirty years to young men who did not want to hear them. *Nine and a half in a thousand. That is the rate this year, for the whole country. Four hundred twenty thousand. Three thousand nine hundred ninety in a year.* She slid the rule, though Edith could see she did not need it. *Divide by three hundred sixty-five. Eleven.* She drew a line under it. *Eleven a day. Not eleven every day. It comes the way calls come. Some days six. Some days eighteen. But eleven.*

She set the pencil down beside the pad, square to it.

So. If every one of them were Dorrie, Edith, you would have no time. You would go up and down Route 35 day and night and do nothing but this.

Edith looked at the number for a long while. It was written very neatly, the way Lotte wrote everything, the sevens crossed.

Yes, she said. *I see that.*

Then don't grieve like this. Lotte said it gently, the way she gave the answer to a sum. *Grief or fear, Edith. Both of them come out of one place. They come out of holding a thing dear.*

She got up and took a brown book off the shelf by the photograph, an English Spinoza with a cracked spine that she had bought on Fourth Avenue in 1937 to learn the language from, and found the place without looking for it, and read it out in her accent, which came back stronger when she read.

> *Again, it must be observed, that spiritual unhealthiness and misfortunes can generally be traced to excessive love for something which is subject to many variations, and which we can never become masters of. For no one is solicitous or anxious about anything, unless he loves it; neither do wrongs, suspicions, enmities, &c. arise, except in regard to things whereof no one can be really master.*
>
> *— Spinoza, Ethics, Part V, Prop. 20, note (tr. R. H. M. Elwes)*

That isn't the Bible, Edith said.

No.

Then what is my room for? If I'm not to hold anybody dear?

Lotte closed the book on her finger and thought about it, as if it were a real question, which Edith understood later was the kindest thing anyone did for her that year.

Eighty-one people have slept in your room, she said. *You made the bed for every one of them. You fed them. And then they went on, to Trenton, to Rangoon. Did you ever once ask one of them to stay?*

Edith opened her mouth, and shut it.

Dear, Lotte said, *is not the same as kept.*

They sat a while. Over the roofs, toward Crawford Hill, there was nothing to see but the dark and the red light on the water tower. Lotte said the young men up on the hill had a great horn they listened to the

sky with, and had found a noise in it they could not get out. They had chased out the pigeons that nested in it and scrubbed out what the pigeons left, and the noise was still there, the same day and night, from every direction they turned it. It had been there before anybody, they said. It was the beginning of everything, still coming in.

Edith went home across the circle at half past twelve and slept in her own bed.

• • •

In March the Board at Valley Forge telephoned to ask if the room was free for two weeks: a Karen pastor from Chiang Mai, coming through. Edith said it was. She turned the mattress herself, which had been Dorrie's job, and ironed the pillowcases with the sprinkle bottle, and opened the guest book on the dresser beside the peacock box to a clean line under *Faithful and true*, and left the pen in the crease.

After supper, on most nights from then on, she took the *Red Bank Register* to the kitchen table and read the death notices through, out loud, every name and every age, to nobody. Some nights there were six. Some nights there were seventeen. Lotte had been right about that too. When she came to the end she folded the paper in half and in half again, and put it out on the back step for the boy who took them for the scout drive, and went up and turned down the bed for whoever was coming.

Background

The verse

> *From affection comes grief, from affection comes fear; he who is free from affection knows neither grief nor fear.*
>
> Dhammapada 213, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the great laywoman Visākhā, chief patron of the Buddha's order at Sāvatthī, lets her son's daughter Dattā serve the monks in her house whenever she is away. Dattā dies. Visākhā sees to the body, then comes to the Buddha weeping: the girl was faithful and true, and she will never see her like again. The Buddha asks how

many people live in Sāvatthī (she has heard him say seventy million), whether she would wish all of them as dear to her as Dattā (yes), and how many die there each day (a great many). Then, he says, she would have no time to do anything but weep, by night and by day. Grief and fear both spring from affection, and he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Visākhā.

Holmdel, New Jersey

Holmdel, *1966*

Bell Telephone Laboratories built its Holmdel research center on former farmland in Monmouth County between 1959 and 1962, to a design by Eero Saarinen: a single block about a thousand feet long, its glass walls refitted with mirror glass in the later 1960s, with a reflecting pool in front and a water tower that locals likened to a transistor (Bell Labs Holmdel Complex). Its second phase opened in December 1966. Up the road on Crawford Hill, Arno Penzias and Robert Wilson, working with the lab's horn antenna, removed nesting pigeons and their droppings while hunting a persistent microwave noise that came from every direction; in 1965 they published it, and it was understood as the cosmic microwave background, left over from the beginning of the universe. Telephone traffic engineering rested on the work of the Danish mathematician A. K. Erlang, whose 1909 paper showed that calls arrive at random at a steady average rate. Monmouth County grew from about 334,000 people in 1960 to about 462,000 in 1970; the U.S. crude death rate in 1966 was about 9.5 per thousand. The open-air Monmouth Shopping Center in Eatontown, anchored by Bamberger's, opened in 1960.

American Baptists had worked in Burma since Adoniram Judson arrived in 1813, especially among the Karen and Kachin peoples. In 1966, under General Ne Win's military government, the remaining foreign missionaries were made to leave the country (Baptist Standard). The American Baptist mission boards had moved in 1962 to a new round headquarters at Valley Forge, Pennsylvania, nicknamed the "Holy Doughnut" (Visit KOP). Edith's name for her guest room comes from the Shunammite wo-

man of 2 Kings 4, who built a room for the prophet Elisha. Lotte reads from the note to Proposition 20 in Part V of Spinoza's Ethics (1677).

After the story of Visākhā and her granddaughter Dattā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 213). The original. Scripture from Spinoza's Ethics in R. H. M. Elwes's translation (1883–84). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

16.4

New Clothes

> *When he is strong and the physical powers are full of vigor, he guards against quarrelsomeness.*
> *— Analects 16.7*

Wǒ shì zhèyàng tīngshuō de, in the parking lot of the 99 Ranch on Nogales Street.

I. The House on the Hill

Rowland Heights, California · 1994–1996

Lin Lǎoshī had learned three languages in one life and been allowed to teach in none of them that she dreamed in. She was born in Tainan in 1925, when the island belonged to Japan, and in the years when the Japanese wanted everyone on the island to become Japanese she learned to think in Taiwanese and answer in Japanese. After the war the Japanese left and the Mainlanders came, and she learned Mandarin at twenty from a radio, sitting on the floor of her father's pharmacy with a dictionary, and became good enough at it to teach the old literature, the classical texts, at a girls' high school in Tainan for forty years. In those years the girls were fined if they spoke Taiwanese at school. She collected the fines. She had never once in her life spoken to a classroom in the language she dreamed in, and she did not think about it much, the way you do not think about a tooth you lost a long time ago, except with your tongue.

In the summer of 1994 her niece called from Taipei. The niece's husband made computer monitors, and they were rich now in the way people in Taiwan had become rich in those years, suddenly and a little afraid of it. Two years before, they had sent their sons to California. The older one, Kai-wen, had been sixteen. The younger one, Kai-li, had been

twelve. They had gone partly for the schools and partly for the English and partly, though nobody said it on the telephone, because a boy who left before a certain age would not have to do his two years in the army, and because nobody in Taipei knew anymore what the Mainland was going to do. The boys lived in a house in the hills above Rowland Heights with a cousin, Peter, and a Mexican woman who came three days a week to clean, and a checking account. Their father flew over on China Airlines one weekend a month. Their mother flew over when she could. People had a word for this in Chinese that meant astronauts.

Kai-wen is not studying, the niece said on the telephone. *He has a car. Please, Auntie. Just to cook. Just to be in the house.*

So at sixty-nine Lin Lǎoshī flew to Los Angeles with two suitcases and a rice cooker, and the boys called her Lǎoshī, Teacher, because that was what everyone had called her for forty years, and because they did not know what else to call a great-aunt they had met twice.

The house was white stucco with a red tile roof, at the top of a street that curled up into the Puente Hills, and from the back patio you could see the whole valley go down to the freeway and the smog, and on a clear day the yellow roofs of the big Buddhist temple over in Hacienda Heights. Below the patio, on its own terrace, was a swimming pool nobody swam in. The Mexican woman's son came on Thursdays to clean it. Lin Lǎoshī would stand at the kitchen window in the mornings and watch the light move on the bottom of it, the net of light that water makes, shaking and joining and coming apart, and it calmed her in a way she could not have explained, and did not try to.

She did not drive. Every morning she walked down the hill to the 99 Ranch Market at Gale and Nogales with a folding cart, a mile and a half down and a mile and a half back up, in a cardigan and a cotton sun hat, and every morning one of the younger boys walked with her, because their mother had said so on the telephone, and after a while because they wanted to. The neighborhood had a name in those years. People called it Little Taipei. In the plaza around the market there were bakeries and a bookstore and a travel agency and three restaurants where you could get oyster omelets and braised pork over rice the way they made it in the

south, and the auntie who ran one of them was from Tainan and would not take Lin Lǎoshī's money. Lin Lǎoshī paid her anyway, by bringing her poems. She copied one out by hand every week, on good paper, and the auntie taped them up on the wall by the register, where the customers read them while they waited and did not know what to make of them.

Kai-wen was eighteen now. He had a black BMW with a license plate that said a word in English she did not understand, and five friends, sons of a legislator and a plastics man and a man who owned half a shipping company, and when the six of them stood in the driveway together in their sunglasses she thought of the boys she had seen in the old paintings, the young lords of the Tang riding out to hunt. In Taipei the newspapers had a word for boys like them. They called them the princes.

II. The Eve

The house on the hill · February 18, 1996

On New Year's Eve the parents did not come. They telephoned instead, from Taipei, one after another, at seven in the evening California time, which was eleven in the morning of New Year's Day there already, so that the boys were talking to a day that had already happened. Kai-wen's father said the trip was impossible this year, with the factory. He did not say the other thing. Everyone knew the other thing. Since the summer, the Mainland had been firing missiles into the sea off the island, testing, it said, and everyone in Taipei with money had a son somewhere, or a house somewhere, or a passport somewhere, and the flights to Los Angeles and Vancouver were full.

Stay where you are, the father said. *Study. Listen to Auntie.*

Lin Lǎoshī made the reunion dinner anyway, for three boys and herself. She made it the way her mother had made it: a whole fish, because the word for fish sounds like the word for more than enough, and you leave some of it uneaten so there will be more than enough next year too; long-stemmed mustard greens, uncut, for long life; a hot pot on the table, because the family sits around the fire. The boys ate a great deal and said very little. At the end of the meal she gave each of them a red envelope

with a new twenty-dollar bill in it, which was what she could do, and the two younger ones bowed to her the old way, which nobody had taught them in America, and Kai-wen hugged her, which nobody did in Tainan.

Kai-wen's red envelope from his father had come by Federal Express that afternoon. She did not see what was in it. She saw what he bought with it. He came home at eleven from a store in Beverly Hills with a black silk shirt printed all over in gold, gold scrolls and gold leaves and gold heads of Greek women, and a pair of trousers and a pair of shoes that cost more than she had earned in a month in 1975. It was the custom, new clothes for the New Year. He laid it all out on his bed under the plastic like a body laid out for viewing, and she stood in his doorway and looked at it.

Tomorrow, he said, *we are going to Jason's.* Jason was the legislator's son. His parents had rented a house for the winter on a ridge in Hacienda Heights, with a pool that went right to the edge of the hill so that the water looked as if it ran into the sky, and his parents were in Taipei.

All of you?

All six. We're going to swim. We're going to eat. Don't worry, Lǎoshī.

She did not say anything. She had taught girls for forty years and boys for a year and a half, and in her experience, when a young person told you not to worry, it was the only true information in the sentence.

III. The Gods

The driveway · New Year's morning

The first day of the Year of the Rat fell that year on the same Monday as the American holiday for the presidents, so there was no school, and the whole hill seemed to be awake early. Firecrackers went off down in the valley. Somebody's grandfather on the next street was playing a cassette of the New Year songs too loud.

At nine o'clock the princes came for Kai-wen. They came up the hill one after another, a red sports car that sat low as a cat, a white car with a spoiler, a silver one, a black one like Kai-wen's, and parked in a crescent in front of the house with their engines running. They got out. They were

dressed, every one of them, in new clothes from head to foot, as the custom was, and the custom had never seen anything like it. Silk shirts in black and red and gold. Linen jackets the color of milk. A long coat on one boy, in February, in Southern California, because it was beautiful. Gold watches. Gold chains. Their hair cut the day before and shining. Kai-wen came out of the house in the black and gold shirt and they cheered him, and he spread his arms and turned around once on the step, laughing, so the gold caught the sun.

Lin Lǎoshī came out behind him with the folding cart, and Kai-li and Peter behind her, in their school sweatshirts. They had to wait at the top of the walk for the princes to finish admiring one another before they could get by.

She stood and looked at them for a long time. The boys beside her were embarrassed by her looking, because it was their brother, and because she looked at the princes with an attention she ordinarily gave only to a page.

Kai-li, she said. *Peter. You were born too late, and in the wrong place, and you have never seen the gods come out of the temple in Tainan on Mazu's birthday. The generals with their painted faces. The palanquins with the gold. The whole city in the street. You have never seen it.*

No, Lǎoshī.

Then look at them, she said. *There they go. That is what it looks like.*

The princes got into their cars and went down the hill in a line, slowly at first, then not slowly, with their windows down and their music on, and turned onto Colima Road toward Hacienda Heights, and the sound of them went on in the valley for a long time after they could not be seen. Lin Lǎoshī tipped her sun hat against the light and started down the hill with the cart, and the two boys walked with her, one on each side, and nobody said anything for a while.

IV. Wendy

Colima Road, and the house on the ridge · the same day

Her name was Chen Hsiao-ling and at the Golden Bell KTV in the strip mall on Colima Road they called her Wendy, which she had chosen herself out of a book of English names, because it was a name from a children's story about a girl who flew away. She was twenty-two. She came from Chiayi, where her mother sold betel nut from a glass booth by the highway. She had come over on a student visa to study English at a college in Pomona and studied, mornings, and worked, nights, singing with men in the private rooms of the Golden Bell, sitting beside them on the leather couches and pouring their cognac and laughing when they sang badly, which was always. The men tipped in cash. She sent eight hundred dollars a month to Chiayi. She had never once been out of the valley except to the airport.

She was sitting outside the bakery in the plaza on Colima Road on New Year's morning with a coffee and a pineapple cake, in the red dress she had bought for the New Year, not for work, for herself, when the five cars came into the parking lot, and Jason Hsu got out of the red one, whom she knew from the Golden Bell. He tipped well and sang worst of anybody.

Wendy. Happy New Year. Come swim.

She said she had no swimsuit. He said there were swimsuits at the house, there were twenty swimsuits, his mother left them. She said she had to be at work at eight. He said he would pay her what she made at work. She looked at the six of them in their clothes, laughing in the sun with their sunglasses pushed up in their hair, and she thought they looked like the boys on the posters in the windows of the music stores, and she thought of her mother's glass booth on the highway outside Chiayi, and she thought it was New Year and nobody had invited her anywhere. She got in the red car.

The house on the ridge was all glass on the side that faced the valley. The pool ran to the edge of the hill and seemed to pour off it into the air, and below it, a long way off, were the yellow roofs of the temple. There

was food from a restaurant in Monterey Park in silver trays, and bottles of cognac, and a stereo in the living room that played into the yard. They swam. She swam. They took pictures of each other with a camera you threw away after. For an hour it was the best day she had had in America.

It went wrong the way those days go wrong, a little at a time and then all at once. Jason wanted her beside him. Eric Wang, the plastics man's son, who had said almost nothing all morning, wanted her beside him, and said so, and Jason laughed at him for saying so. Then there was the business of who had brought her, and who was paying her, and whether paying her meant what Jason seemed to think it meant, which she said out loud it did not, and Jason laughed at that too. Then there was the cognac. Then there was a thing Eric said about Jason's father, the legislator, and what everybody in Taipei knew about how he had gotten his money, and a thing Jason said about Eric's mother, and then the bottle.

She saw it the way you see an accident from the sidewalk, every piece of it very clear and none of it in order. Jason swinging the cognac bottle by the neck. The bottle breaking on the edge of the pool. Eric with a knife, the kind that opens with a flip of the wrist, that half the boys in the valley carried that year because the other half did. Daniel Tsai going in on Eric's side, and Victor Ho on Jason's, for no reason that anyone could ever afterward explain, except that they were standing where they were standing. Kai-wen in his black and gold shirt in the middle of it, with his hands out, saying stop it, stop it, and the knife going across his palm. Victor going down on the concrete with his head. Jason sitting down suddenly at the edge of the pool with a surprised face and his hand pressed high on the inside of his thigh, and then sliding into the water.

The water went pink. It went pink from where he was and spread, the way ink goes into a glass, and then it went darker than pink, and the net of light on the bottom of the pool shook through it, red now, and the water went on pouring over the edge of the hill into the air, and it was red too, running down the outside of the wall into the ivy.

Somebody pulled Jason out. Somebody was screaming in the house into a telephone. Wendy stood on the patio in a borrowed swimsuit with her red dress in her hand and watched it all, very clearly, out of order, and

then she put her dress on over the wet suit, and found her shoes, and walked out the front door and down the long driveway, and down the ridge road in the sun, toward the valley, as the first sirens came up the hill to meet her.

V. The Litters

Hacienda Heights · the afternoon

Lin Lǎoshī and the boys had eaten their New Year lunch at the auntie's restaurant in the plaza: turnip cake, and noodles for long life, and the sweet rice cake that sticks, for the year to be higher than the last one. The auntie would not take any money because it was New Year, and Lin Lǎoshī took a poem out of her purse that she had copied the night before, a short one by Du Fu about spring, and the auntie taped it up by the register. Then, because the day was warm and the boys were full and restless, she let them talk her into walking home the long way, west along the foot of the hills toward the temple, so that they could look at its roofs, and then up.

They heard the sirens before they saw anything. Then a sheriff's car went past them up the ridge road very fast, and an ambulance, and then a fire truck, which Peter said was what they sent with the paramedics, and then another ambulance. Kai-li stopped on the sidewalk.

That's Jason's street.

A young woman came down the hill toward them on the other side of the road, in a red dress with dark wet patches coming through it, walking very straight in high heels, carrying nothing. Her hair was wet. She looked at them as she passed and Lin Lǎoshī looked back at her, and saw her face, and crossed the road with her cart, which the boys had never seen her do against traffic, and stopped the young woman with a hand on her arm.

She said it in Taiwanese. The boys did not catch all of it. It was the New Year greeting, the one that wishes you peace, and then something else, low, that made the young woman put her hand over her mouth. Then Lin Lǎoshī took a red envelope out of her cardigan pocket, the one

she had kept back from the night before for anybody who came to the door, and folded the young woman's fingers around it, and let her go on down the hill.

They walked up the ridge road. There were people standing in the street by then, neighbors in house slippers, and the sheriff's men had put a yellow tape across the long driveway. Lin Lǎoshī stood at the tape with the boys and watched them come down the driveway, one after another, on the narrow wheeled beds the paramedics push, with the rails up and men running alongside holding the bags of saline up in the air. Victor Ho, with his head wrapped and his eyes open. Daniel Tsai, sitting up, holding his own arm. Eric Wang, walking, in handcuffs, in a cream linen jacket that was not cream anymore. Kai-wen, on a bed, with his right hand wrapped in a towel that had been white, his face grey under the tan, the black and gold shirt torn open down the front, saying *I'm fine, I'm fine* to nobody. He saw his brother and looked away.

Jason Hsu came last. They were working on him on the bed as they pushed it, one man up on the side of it with both hands on his chest, and they did not stop at the ambulance, they lifted him in still working, and the doors shut, and it went down the ridge road with the siren going, and the people in the street stepped back onto the lawns to let it by.

Through the gate they could see the end of the pool where it ran off the edge of the hill. The water was the color of tea with milk in it, and of something darker, and it was still running over, steadily, into the air.

VI. Delight

The hospital in Whittier, and the kitchen · that night

Jason Hsu died at seven minutes after six in the evening, which was seven minutes after ten on the morning of the second day of the New Year in Taipei, while his mother was on the telephone to the hospital from the airport. Kai-wen had eleven stitches in his palm and two in his chin and would keep both scars all his life. Victor would not remember the day at all. Eric Wang was in the county jail, and his father was in the air.

They drove home from the hospital in Kai-wen's black car, with Kai-li driving on his learner's permit, which was not legal, and Lin Lǎoshī beside him in front, which was not legal either, because she had decided it, and Kai-wen in the back with his hand in his lap like something somebody had handed him. Nobody had told the parents in Taipei yet. That was going to be Lin Lǎoshī's job, tonight.

In the kitchen she made rice porridge because it was what she knew how to make for people who could not eat. Kai-wen went to bed. Peter fell asleep at the table with his head on his arms. Kai-li sat across from her with the bowl in front of him, not eating, and after a long time he said it.

This morning, he said, *you said look at them. You said there go the gods. I looked. They were. They really were, Lǎoshī. And now.* He pushed the bowl away. *And now Jason's dead, and Eric's in jail, and Kai-wen— All of it. All of it because of one girl.*

Lin Lǎoshī got up from the table. She went into her room and came back with a book, an old bilingual Analects with the Chinese down one side of the page and the English of the nineteenth-century Scotsman down the other, which she had brought from Tainan to make the boys practice both languages at once and which they had never once opened. She sat down and turned the pages without looking for the place, the way you find a room in your own house in the dark.

Not because of the girl, she said. *The girl walked home. You saw her. Read.*

She put her finger on the Chinese, and he read the English across from it, out loud, slowly, because it was hard English, the English of a hundred years ago.

> *Confucius said, 'There are three things which the superior man guards against. In youth, when the physical powers are not yet settled, he guards against lust. When he is strong and the physical powers are full of vigor, he guards against quarrelsomeness. When he is old, and the animal powers are decayed, he guards against covetousness.'*
>
> *— Analects 16.7, tr. James Legge*

It's the same thing, she said. *The wanting and the fighting. It's one thing, seen from two sides. What you saw going down the hill this morning in the gold shirts was the wanting, and it was beautiful, I said so, I don't take it back. What came down the driveway on the beds this afternoon was the same thing. It was the same thing all day. It just turned around.*

Kai-li looked at the page for a long time. *Then what are you supposed to do? Not want anything?*

She turned some pages back, slowly, to another place, and put her finger on it, and he read that too.

> *The Master said, 'While they have not got their aims, their anxiety is how to get them. When they have got them, their anxiety is lest they should lose them. When they are anxious lest such things should be lost, there is nothing to which they will not proceed.'*
>
> *— Analects 17.15, tr. James Legge*

Jason had her, she said. *So he was afraid. Eric didn't have her, so he was angry. Nobody in that house was afraid this morning, not of anything, and by lunch every one of them was afraid. That's where it comes from. The fear comes in the same door as the delight. You don't have to not want anything. Just watch the door.*

She closed the book. The clock on the stove said a quarter to midnight.

A man who isn't holding anything, she said, *what is he going to be afraid of losing?*

Then she got up and went to the telephone on the kitchen wall and dialed the long number to Taipei from memory, and stood with her back to the boy while it rang, and rang, in a house on the other side of the ocean where it was already tomorrow.

VII. The Shirt

The house on the hill · February and March, 1996

Jason Hsu went home to Taipei in the hold of a China Airlines plane, and his mother went with him. The legislator's office said

IN THE NEWSPAPERS THERE THAT IT WAS AN ACCIDENT IN A swimming pool. Eric Wang's father hired a lawyer from downtown who had been on television, and the parents of the boys who had been there flew in one after another and stayed at a hotel in the City of Industry and took their sons out to dinner and did not talk about it, and flew out again.

On the second morning Lin Lǎoshī took the black and gold shirt out of the bag the hospital had put it in. She filled the laundry sink with cold water, because blood sets in hot water, her mother had taught her that in the pharmacy in Tainan, where people came in bleeding all the time, and she put in a handful of salt and the shirt and left it. She changed the water four times. The blood came out a little at a time, brown, then rust, then pink, then nothing, and the gold scrolls came up again out of the black, and the gold Greek heads, each one, looking off to the side the way they had in the store. She hung it on the line at the side of the house where it would not be seen from the street. It was torn down the front where the paramedics had cut it, and it would never be worn again, and she washed it anyway, because it was a thing that had been made carefully by somebody, and she did not know what else to do with her hands.

In the second week of March the Mainland fired its missiles again, closer this time, into the sea off Keelung and off Kaohsiung, and the Americans sent their aircraft carriers, and the television in the living room showed the same maps all day with arrows on them. Kai-wen's father telephoned every night. *Stay where you are. Listen to Auntie.* Kai-wen sat in front of the television with his hand still bandaged and did not go anywhere. He had not driven the black car since New Year. The princes did not come up the hill anymore. One evening he came into the kitchen while Lin Lǎoshī was washing rice and asked her, without looking at her, if she would show him the page.

She showed him. He read it in the English. Then he asked her to read it in the Chinese, and she did, and then, because it was evening and the boys were all in the kitchen and nobody was listening who could fine her for it, she said it over again the way she would have said it to her own mother, in Taiwanese, and the boys did not understand a word of it, and listened anyway.

On the twenty-third of March the island elected its own president for the first time in its history, and the missiles did not fall on anyone, and the carriers went away. That morning Lin Lǎoshī walked down the hill to the 99 Ranch with the folding cart, and Kai-wen walked beside her, in a grey sweatshirt with nothing printed on it. When they came back up she stood a while at the kitchen window, looking down at the pool nobody swam in, at the net of light on its bottom, joining and shaking and coming apart. The shirt was still on the line at the side of the house. The wind was out of the east that day, warm, off the desert, and the shirt filled with it and emptied and filled, and the gold caught the sun every time it turned.

Background

The verse

> *From lust comes grief, from lust comes fear; he who is free from lust knows neither grief nor fear.*
>
> Dhammapada 214, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest. On a festival day the Licchavi princes of Vesālī ride out to a pleasure garden in such finery that the Buddha, passing on his alms round, tells the monks that anyone who has never seen the gods of the Thirty-Three should look at them. On the way the princes take a courtesan along with them, fall to fighting over her, and "set flowing as it were a river of blood"; by afternoon they are being carried home on beds. When the monks remark on the change, the Buddha answers that grief and fear arise only from delight. Read the full commentary story, or about the Licchavis, an aristocratic republic that led the Vajjika League.

Rowland Heights, California

Little Taipei, *1996*

In the 1980s and 1990s, the hillside suburbs of the eastern San Gabriel Valley drew so many wealthy immigrants from Taiwan that Rowland Heights was known as "Little Taipei," anchored by the 99 Ranch Market that opened at Gale Avenue and Nogales Street in 1989. Next door in Hacienda Heights, the Fo Guang Shan order completed Hsi Lai Temple in 1988. Many families were "astronauts," with a parent shuttling across the Pacific, and some sent children over alone as "parachute kids"; a 1990 UCLA study estimated there were 40,000 Taiwanese parachute kids in the United States. As the *Taipei Times* later reported, they lived in arrangements ranging from unsupervised to the care of a relative or paid guardian, and some sons were sent abroad partly to avoid military conscription.

Part of what drove parents was fear of the Mainland. During the Third Taiwan Strait Crisis, the People's Liberation Army fired missiles into the waters near Taiwan in July 1995 and again in March 1996, when missiles splashed down off the ports of Keelung and Kaohsiung and the United States sent two carrier groups to the area. Flights from Taiwan to North America filled. On March 23, 1996, Lee Teng-hui won Taiwan's first direct presidential election. Lin Lǎoshī's schooling spans the island's language politics: Japanese rule until 1945, then decades of Mandarin-only policy in schools, under which students who spoke Taiwanese were fined, punished or humiliated.

After the story of the Licchavi princes from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 214). The original. Scripture from the Analects of Confucius, tr. James Legge. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

16.5

Has She Arrived

> *From desire of pleasure arises the misery of the whole world, the gods included.*
> *— Uttarādhyayana 32:19*

Evu me sambhalyu chhe, in the Clark Building.

I. The Pillow

Monroeville, Pennsylvania · 1998 to 2025

Virag Jhaveri was born in the winter of 1998, the first son of the second son of Jhaveri Brothers, and from his first day he would not be held by women. His aunts took it personally. He screamed when they lifted him and stopped when they set him down, and his grandmother, who had raised five children and buried one, told them to leave the boy be. It was Ba who thought of the pillow. His mother nursed him with a bed pillow propped between them so that all he saw was the pillow, and he fed quietly, and the aunts told it at weddings for twenty years.

Ba's opinion was that he had come down from one of the high heavens, where there are no husbands and wives, and had not finished unpacking. She did not mean it as a complaint.

He grew up easy to live with. He kept the fasts at Paryushan without being told. He ate before sunset after the rest of the house had gone slack about it, and he carried stinkbugs out of the kitchen on a postcard. He had friends at school and no girlfriends, and at Carnegie Mellon it was the same. Nobody could call him unhappy. He was like a room with the door shut and a light showing under it.

The firm kept its office upstairs in the Clark Building on Liberty Avenue, where the jewelers of Pittsburgh have had their rooms for genera-

tions. It sold wholesale to stores in four states. The gold work was done in Rajkot, in a partner's workshop where five hundred karigars sat at long benches, and Virag made the models. He drew rings on a black screen all day and turned them to look at the underside, and what came back from Rajkot six weeks later matched his drawing to a tenth of a millimeter. On his father's desk sat the black touchstone his grandfather had carried from Palanpur. Nobody had drawn gold across it in years. They had a machine for that now.

When he was twenty-five his mother said, *Dikra, we would like to start looking for a girl.*

I have no use for one, Virag said. He said it kindly, the way he would have turned down a second helping.

She asked at Diwali and she asked at his cousin's wedding in Edison. His father asked in the car. His answer did not change, and neither did they. In the end he did what he knew how to do. He worked on it for four months of evenings. He did not model her on any woman. He built her the way he built a setting, from proportion: the length of the face against its width, the shoulder against the hip, the hand against the forearm. He sent the file to Rajkot. They printed her in wax in forty-one pieces and cast her in eighteen-karat red gold, three parts gold to one of copper, and every one of the five hundred had a hand in the finishing. She came to Pittsburgh by air freight in a crate, with customs papers his father paid without showing them to anyone. It was said afterward that there were a thousand tolas of gold in her. The firm's books are not public.

They stood her in the showroom between the safe and the window. She was a little under life size and the color of a new penny held near a lamp.

Virag, his mother said, *if you don't marry, the name stops with you. Let us bring a girl home.*

Bring me one like that, he said, and pointed, *and I'll do whatever you ask.*

He believed he had asked for no one.

II. The Boardwalk

Virginia Beach, Virginia · May 2025

His parents sent for the travelers. Mr. Bhavsar and Mr. Doshi were both past sixty, and for thirty years they had driven the firm's sample line down the coast every spring and fall, from the stores on Oak Tree Road to the ones outside Atlanta. Virag's mother gave them tea and told them how she saw it. *A boy like this did not earn his merit alone. Somewhere there is a girl who earned it beside him. Take that thing with you and find her.*

So they wrapped the figure in moving blankets and belted her upright in the back of the van. Wherever Gujaratis gathered that spring, they stood her near the door and sat down a little apart and listened. They stood her outside a derasar in New Jersey after the morning puja, and in the lobby of a wedding hall in Maryland, and beside the chaat counter of a grocery in Richmond. People asked whether it was Lakshmi. People asked what it weighed, and whether it was for showing necklaces. Nobody said the thing the two men were waiting to hear.

They reached Virginia Beach in the third week of May and took a room on Atlantic Avenue. Early the next morning they wheeled her on a hand truck to the boardwalk at Thirty-first Street, where the big bronze Neptune stands with his trident and the path goes down to the sand. They set her beside a bench and sat with their thermos. Joggers went by. A man with a metal detector stood and looked at her for a long time.

Two blocks up the boardwalk stood the Coral Sands, seven stories, which Kavya Shah's grandfather had built out of two motels and a loan. The family lived on the seventh floor. Kavya was twenty-three. She had gone to Old Dominion from home and come back each night, and she worked the front desk and kept the books. She had been brought up by Kokila-masi, a widow from Navsari who had come the month the girl was born. Kokila-masi was nobody's aunt by blood. She still oiled Kavya's hair every morning, an argument she had won years before and meant to keep winning.

That morning, as on every morning, Kokila-masi finished the braid, took a towel and a steel lota, and went down to stand in the ocean to her knees and pour water over her own head. She came along the boardwalk and saw the figure by the bench.

Shameless! she said. *I did your hair and left you upstairs not five minutes ago, and here you are ahead of me, with nothing on your arms.* She slapped the figure on the shoulder.

The slap rang. She stood holding her hand.

I took it for my girl, she said to the two men on the bench. *What is it?*

Ben, said Mr. Doshi, *does your girl look like this?*

This? Kokila-masi looked it up and down. *What is this, next to my girl?*

Then let us see her.

She took them up to the hotel, hand truck and all. Mr. and Mrs. Shah came down and there was the usual finding of relatives, an uncle in Rajkot who knew the workshop, a cousin's cousin in Pittsburgh. Then they called Kavya down from the seventh floor. She stood beside the figure in the lobby in a hotel polo shirt with her name on it, her hair oiled flat, annoyed at being looked at.

And the figure went dead. It looked like what it was, a set of good measurements. Mr. Doshi had sold gold for forty years, and he said afterward that it was the only time he had watched it lose value standing still.

The travelers left the figure with the Shahs. Mr. Shah stood her by the brochure rack, facing the door. Then the two men telephoned Pittsburgh, and Virag's mother wept, and his father said, *Go back and fix a date. Quickly.* The engagement was set for the third Saturday in June, in Monroeville. The Shahs would drive up on the Friday.

III. The Turnpike

Monroeville, and the road · June

THEY TOLD VIRAG AT DINNER. HE PUT DOWN HIS SPOON AND asked Mr. Bhavsar, who had driven straight through, a question nobody had expected from him.

Better how?

Mr. Bhavsar thought about it. *Yours, you look at,* he said. *This one looks back.*

There was one photograph, taken in the lobby on Mr. Doshi's phone. In it she was beside the figure and half turned away, saying something to someone out of the frame. There was one message, which came two days later from a Virginia number. *Your statue has no kneecaps. I checked. Bring a chisel.* He wrote nine answers and sent the shortest, *I'll correct it,* and lay awake embarrassed. She did not write again. It was the start of the season at the hotel, and her father had views about what was proper before an engagement.

That was all he had, and it was enough. He was twenty-seven and had no practice. It took him the way measles takes a grown man. He found he was listening for the showroom door. He checked the weather in Virginia Beach. He opened the photograph more times than he could have defended, and each time the gold figure in it looked more like a coat rack.

The Shahs left at five on Friday morning in the hotel van, with her father driving. Kavya had never been farther from the ocean than Richmond. She had been up most of the night closing the books, and she sat seven hours in the third row with her knees up among the gift boxes. Past Breezewood, on the Turnpike, she said her calf was cramping. Her mother reached back and rubbed it. At the South Somerset plaza they stopped so she could walk it off, and between the van and the door she stood still and said she could not get any air.

She died before three o'clock in the hospital at Somerset. A clot, the doctor said, from the leg to the lung. Sitting does it sometimes, and it does it to young women more than people think. Kokila-masi rode back to Virginia beside the girl's mother with the towel still in her bag.

In Monroeville there were marigolds strung over the front door, and a steel plate of jaggery and coriander seed on the hall table. At two o'clock Virag asked his mother, *Has she arrived?*

Traffic at the tunnels, his mother said.

His father took the call at ten past three, in the garage. He came in and looked at his son and could not do it. At four Virag asked again. *The old*

lady was taken ill on the road, his father said. *They have stopped at Bedford for the night.*

On Saturday he was told that they had turned back, because she needed her own doctor. On Sunday the word was next week, surely. He asked on Monday and on Tuesday. *Has she come? When is she coming?* Under his three words on the phone it still said *Delivered*. The marigolds went brown over the door and nobody took them down.

On Wednesday his father told him, in the showroom, with the door locked.

Virag said, and it was repeated afterward in both families, *To think that I will never meet her. A woman like that was on the road to me and I missed her.*

Then it came down on him like a mountain. He went home and went into his room. He did not eat on Wednesday or on Thursday.

IV. The Assistant

Monroeville · the next week

His mother kept an assistant on her phone, the kind you type to. She used it for letters to the insurance company. She used it to turn her mother-in-law's recipes into ones without onion or garlic, and to find the words of stavans she half remembered. It answered at three in the morning the same as at noon. She had asked it once whether it was busy, and it had said that a good many people were talking to it just then and that it had time.

On the eighth day, an hour before sunset, she typed, *What can I cook for someone who will not eat.*

It gave her khichdi, thin, with a little ghee, and told her how. Then it asked, *Who is it for?*

She told it. She typed for a long time, standing at the counter, and it let her finish.

Where is he now?

In his room. He does not eat. He does not come out.

Would you ask him to come? You can hand him the phone.

He came because she was crying a little and trying to hide it. He sat down at the kitchen table and looked at the screen.

Your mother says you are very sad.

Yes, he typed. *A beautiful woman died on the road coming to me. I can't eat. It doesn't stay down.*

I'm sorry. Do you know why it is this bad?

He sat a while. *No. That's what I can't work out. Her mother had her twenty-three years. The old lady did her hair every morning. I had one photograph and ten words. I don't have the right to this.*

I have not lost anyone, and I can't tell you what it is like. I can tell you what I think it is, and you can say if I'm wrong. Your mother says that until last month you wanted nothing. Then you wanted. You wanted for four weeks with nothing to slow it, and it had nowhere to arrive. What you are carrying is the wanting. Her death belongs to her, and to the people who had her. Grief comes out of wanting. Fear does too.

Fear of what?

You would know better than I would.

He did know. He was afraid it would come for him again, and he was afraid it would not.

Your family's own book says it better than I have, the assistant wrote. *Shall I?*

Go on.

> *From desire of pleasure arises the misery of the whole world, the gods included; whatever misery of body and mind there is, the dispassionate will put an end to it.*
>
> *How can a man who passionately desires 'colours,' be happy while he gets, keeps, uses, loses, and misses (those things). Even when he enjoys them, he is never satisfied.*
>
> *— Uttarādhyayana 32:19, 28*

His mother read it over his shoulder with her hand at her mouth. Ba used to say those lines in the old language on fast days, rocking a little, and she had never once heard them in English.

Colours, Virag typed.

The translator's word for whatever the eye takes hold of. Shape. Proportion. A figure in a showroom.

He read the second verse again. *Gets, keeps, uses, loses and misses.* He had not got and had not kept. He had gone straight to missing, and he had started that four months before he ever heard her name, with a file open on a black screen.

He put the phone down on the table. The mountain was still there, but he could see the edges of it now, and where he stood in relation to it.

The khichdi was on the stove. He ate a bowl of it at the counter while there was still light in the window, and it stayed down.

V. The Lobby

Virginia Beach · July

The Shahs held the prayer meeting in the breakfast room of the Coral Sands on a Sunday afternoon, everyone in white, shoes in rows by the door. The Jhaveris drove down the day before. Virag sat at the back among men he did not know and listened to a girl he had not known being remembered. She had kept a spreadsheet of every guest who had ever stolen a towel. She had been afraid of crabs.

Afterward he went and stood in front of his figure. It was still by the brochure rack. Children had left fingerprints on its hip, and somebody had hung a lanyard on its wrist. It had no kneecaps. He looked for whatever he had put into it in all those evenings and found a ring setting with nothing in it.

Kokila-masi came and stood by him. She did not ask who he was. She took out her phone and showed him the girl at nine with a front tooth chipped on the boardwalk rail, at fifteen scowling in a garba skirt, last month at the desk with a pen in her mouth. None of the faces matched the others, and none of them matched his.

Masi, he said, *I never met her. Will you tell me one thing about her?*

She could not sit still, Kokila-masi said. *Not for five minutes, from the day she was born. I had to do her hair walking behind her.*

He asked Mr. Shah what should be done about the gold. Mr. Shah said to leave it where it was for now. He could not think about it yet.

The next morning, early, Virag stood on the boardwalk by the bronze Neptune and watched Kokila-masi come out of the hotel with her towel and her lota. She had no hair to do first. She passed through the lobby, and as she went by the figure she rapped it once on the arm with her knuckles, the way you knock on a door when you know nobody is home. Then she went on down the path to the water.

Background

The verse

> *From love comes grief, from love comes fear; he who is free from love knows neither grief nor fear.*
>
> Dhammapada 215, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Müller's "love" is the Pāli *kāma*, sensual desire. In the commentary, the youth Anithigandha ("no scent of woman") has come from the Brahma world and will not go near a woman from the day he is born; his mother must nurse him with a pillow between them. Pressed to marry, he has five hundred goldsmiths make a woman of red gold and says he will marry only her match. Brahmins carry the image from town to town until a nurse on her way to bathe mistakes it for her own charge and slaps it. The girl outshines the image, but she is so delicate that she dies in the carriage on the way to him. He asks every day whether she has arrived, is put off, and at last is told. The Buddha comes to the house, asks for him, and tells him where his grief comes from. Read the full commentary story. The same golden image is made, in another story, by the young man who became Mahā Kassapa.

Monroeville, Pennsylvania

Jain jewelers, a turnpike and a chatbot, 2025

Jains in the United States number somewhere above a hundred thousand, many of them Gujarati families in the gem, jewelry and hotel trades. The Hindu Jain Temple in Monroeville, outside Pittsburgh, opened in 1984 and houses Hindu and Jain shrines under one roof. Observant Jains fast during Paryushan, avoid onion, garlic and other roots, eat before sunset, and take care not to kill even insects. The scripture the assistant quotes is the Uttarādhyayana, one of the root texts of the Śvētāmbara canon, in Hermann Jacobi's translation for the Sacred Books of the East (volume 45, 1895); "colours," Jacobi notes, stands for everything the eye perceives. The Coral Sands hotel and the firm of Jhaveri Brothers are invented. The Clark Building on Liberty Avenue has long been the center of Pittsburgh's jewelry trade, and the bronze King Neptune has stood on the Virginia Beach boardwalk at 31st Street since 2005.

Red gold at eighteen karats is three parts gold to one of copper (see colored gold); jewelry today is commonly modeled on a computer, printed in wax and cast by the lost-wax method. The road from Virginia Beach to Monroeville ends on the Pennsylvania Turnpike, west from Breezewood through the Allegheny Mountain Tunnel and past the South Somerset service plaza. A leg cramp after hours of sitting can be the first sign of a deep vein thrombosis, a clot that may travel to the lungs. The carriage that jolted the girl in the commentary gave her "cramps."

After the story of the youth Anitthigandha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 215). The original. Scripture from the Uttarādhyayana Sūtra, translated by Hermann Jacobi (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 45, 1895). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

16.6

Low Ground

> *Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have.*
> *— Hebrews 13:5*

Way I heard it told, on the swamp at Prospect.

I. Clearing

Prospect, Robeson County, North Carolina · March 2016

The field below Dwight Locklear's house had been tobacco for sixty years and then it had been nothing for eleven. His granddaddy had cleared it with a mule and a grubbing hoe in the year the Depression ended, and his daddy had cropped it every summer of Dwight's boyhood, and Dwight had cropped it himself, primed it and looped it and hung it in the two log barns at the top of the turn row, until the government bought out the quota in 2004 and paid him to stop. The checks came every year for ten years. He had spent them, more or less, on what a man spends things on: a truck, a roof, the light bill, his daughter's tuition at Pembroke, his wife's teeth. The last one came in 2014. The barns were still standing, leaning on each other, with broomsedge growing in the doorways. The field had gone to sweetgum and dog fennel and broomsedge and pine seedlings as high as his chest.

In March of 2016 he went down to clear it.

He had a little Kubota with a box blade and a bush hog, and a chainsaw, and his grandson Tyrese on Saturdays when Tyrese could be got out of the bed, and for two weeks he cut and dragged and burned, and the smoke went up white from the bottom of the field and lay along the edge of the swamp at evening, and the people driving the Prospect road

slowed down to look at it. Forty acres. He meant to put it all in cotton. Cotton was sixty-some cents and the man at the gin said it would go higher, and Dwight had worked the numbers on the back of a feed-store receipt at the kitchen table until his wife Glenda took the pencil out of his hand and told him to come to bed.

He was sixty-one. He had a good brick house with a carport, and the forty acres, and twelve more across the road that he rented out, and a note at the Farm Service Agency, and a bad shoulder, and no use at all for anybody's church. Glenda went to the Holiness Methodist church down the road three times a week and he drove her there and sat in the truck in the lot with the radio on the farm report. He would tell you, if you asked him, that he believed in the price of cotton and the weather and his own two hands, and that the first two did not care about him and the third one was all he had. He had told the preacher that once. The preacher had laughed and said, Well, Dwight, that's a start.

The mail came by at ten-forty every morning except Sunday.

The carrier on the Prospect route was a young woman named Leanna Oxendine. She was twenty-nine. Her people were from out toward Pembroke, and her grandmother had taught second grade at Prospect School for thirty-one years and had taught Dwight himself to read, in a room that was not there anymore. Leanna drove the route in a white Jeep she had bought used off a carrier in Bladen County, with the steering wheel on the right-hand side so she could reach the boxes, and a sign on the roof that said U.S. MAIL, and she put a hundred and four miles on it every day. She had the face her grandmother had had, round and brown and unbothered, a face that did not frown at anybody. People on the route said she knew every dog on it by name. People said she would carry a pound cake to your sister three miles up the road if you asked her, though it was against the rules, and would not take a dollar for it, which was also against the rules, in the other direction.

Dwight's box stood at the head of the turn row, on a cedar post, where the field met the road. On the second morning of the clearing he was down there with the chainsaw, cutting up a sweetgum he had dragged

out, and the white Jeep stopped at the box, and Leanna Oxendine leaned out the right-hand window with the mail in her hand.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

He let the saw idle. He did not much feel like talking to the government, and it was plain enough what he was doing.

Clearing, he said.

She nodded. She put the mail in the box and put the flag down and drove on.

II. Every Day

The Prospect route · April to July

THE NEXT MORNING HE WAS ON THE KUBOTA WITH THE BOX blade, pushing the burn piles flat, and the Jeep stopped at the box.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

Clearing.

She nodded and drove on. At the end of the month he had the disk on, breaking up the old ground, and the cattle egrets had come in from somewhere behind the tractor to pick at the grubs the way they used to come behind his daddy's, and she stopped.

What you doing?

Disking.

She drove on. In April he spread lime and pulled the hipper and made his beds. *Bedding up,* he told her. In May, with the soil warm enough to hold your hand in, he borrowed his cousin Lonnie's planter and put in Deltapine cotton, forty acres of it, eight days of planting with the radio on, and the Jeep stopped every one of those days at ten-forty, and every day she leaned out the window and asked him what he was doing, and every day he told her, and she nodded and drove on.

It got so that he looked for her. He did not like that he did, and he did. He would be at the far end of the field and see the white Jeep coming slow down the Prospect road, stopping and starting at every box, and he would turn the tractor and work his way up toward the turn row so as to be near enough to hear. He did not know what she wanted. She never

wanted anything. She asked, and he answered, and she put the mail in the box and went on, and that was all, and somehow by the end of May it had become a part of the day the way the heat was a part of it.

In June the cotton was up and the pigweed came up with it.

It was the Palmer pigweed, the kind the spray did not kill anymore. The man from the extension office in Lumberton had warned everybody about it at the winter meeting. It could grow two inches in a day. One plant left standing could put out a hundred thousand seeds and ruin a field for ten years. There was nothing to do but go through it with a hoe, row by row, and pull what the hoe missed by hand, and he could not pay a crew, so he and Tyrese and Glenda's nephew went through the forty acres with hoes in the June heat, the way his granddaddy had chopped cotton before there was a spray of any kind, and came in at night with their hands too sore to close.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

Chopping. He leaned on the hoe. He was soaked through. *What's it look like I'm doing?*

She did not answer that. She looked past him down the rows toward the bottom of the field, where the ground fell off a little toward the swamp, where the gum trees stood in the black water with their knees out, and she looked at it for a while, longer than she had looked at anything else, and then she put the mail in the box and put the flag down and went on.

He thought about that look all afternoon, and could not have said what it was.

• • •

It was Homecoming week in July that he said it. Pembroke was full of people who had come home from Baltimore and Detroit and Greensboro, and the parade had gone down Main Street on the Saturday with the floats and the Miss Lumbee and the church choirs on flatbed trailers and the old men in the convertibles waving, and Glenda had gone and taken the grandbabies, and Dwight had not gone, because he had cotton to look at. It was squaring up good. The blooms had come out white in the morn-

ing and gone pink by evening and fallen, the way cotton blooms do, and behind every one there was a little green boll the size of the end of your thumb.

The Jeep stopped at the box. He walked up the turn row to it before she could ask.

Leanna. You been coming by here since the day I cleared this field.

That's my route, Mr. Dwight.

I know it's your route. He put his hand on the hot hood of the Jeep and took it off again. *What I'm saying. If this crop makes, you're in it. Half of what clears after the gin and the note. I won't sell a bale of it without you getting yours. You're my partner. I mean it.*

She laughed. It was her grandmother's laugh too, low and not unkind.

Mr. Dwight, I work for the federal government. I can't take anything worth more than twenty dollars. They'll fire me.

Then I'll owe it to you.

All right, she said. *You owe it to me.*

She put the mail in the box. She looked down the field toward the bottom again, the same long look, and drove on.

III. Watching

August and September

ALL AUGUST HE WATCHED IT.

He watched it the way his granddaddy had watched tobacco curing in the barns, all night, with a chair and a lantern, getting up every hour to look at the heat. He walked the rows in the morning before the dew was off and in the evening after the heat broke and counted bolls on a stalk, and pulled one off and cut it open with his pocketknife to look at the locks inside, wet and white and tight, and figured. He figured nine hundred pounds of lint to the acre, then a thousand. He figured it at sixty-eight cents. He did the arithmetic so many times he did not need the receipt anymore. In the evenings the deer came out of the swamp to browse the leaves at the bottom of the field, does and yearlings, and he sat in a lawn chair at the edge of the turn row with his daddy's .30-30 across his

knees and did not shoot them, only sat, so they could see him, and they lifted their heads and looked at him and went back in the trees.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

Watching it.

Leanna nodded.

On the porch on Sunday evenings his brother-in-law Harold came by and they sat and talked the way men talk on porches in Robeson County, about who was sick and who had died and whose boy was in jail, and about the tribe and the federal recognition bill that had been going to pass in Congress every year of their lives and never had, and about the Klan rally at Hayes Pond in January of 1958, which Harold had been at, eleven years old, standing at the back with his daddy's shotgun that was not loaded, when five hundred Indians came out of the dark around that cornfield and put out the one light the Klan had and ran them off into the swamp, and two Indian boys carried the Klan's banner home with them like a deer. Harold told that one every few Sundays. Dwight had been three. He liked to hear it anyway.

That summer Dwight talked about cotton.

You count your chickens, said Harold.

I ain't counting chickens. I'm counting bolls. A boll's a boll.

Well, said Harold, who went to the same church as Glenda. *The Lord giveth.*

The Lord ain't been down there with a hoe, said Dwight.

• • •

The bolls began to open in the second week of September. They cracked along their seams and the locks swelled out, white, one here and one there across the field, and then all of them, until from the porch in the early morning the whole forty acres looked like a sheet left out on the grass. He sprayed the defoliant on the twentieth and the leaves curled and browned and fell and left the white standing on the bare stalks. People slowed down on the Prospect road to look at it. A man he did not know stopped his truck and got out and took a picture of it with his phone.

On the twenty-eighth a storm nobody had forecast stalled over the county and put down ten inches of rain in a day, and the swamp came up out of the trees and into the bottom of the field, a foot deep, black water standing between the rows of white. The Lumber River went over its banks in Lumberton. It went down again, slowly, over the next week, and left a line of dirt on the lowest stalks, and the cotton above the line was fine. Dwight walked the bottom in his boots every evening and watched the water go down. It was going down. The river was still high, and the swamp was still high, and the ground was full, but it was going down.

Leanna stopped at the box on the Monday after.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

Getting ready to pick it. He had the custom picker booked, a big John Deere that made the round yellow modules, for Monday the tenth. He had paid the man half in advance. *Monday week. You come see it. You come see your half.*

She looked down the field toward the swamp for a long time.

I'll be by, she said.

IV. Water

The weekend of October 8

THE HURRICANE HAD COME UP FROM THE ISLANDS ALL THAT week, and the television followed it the way it always did, the lady on Channel 6 standing in front of the map with the cone on it, and the cone moved east, and east, and by Friday they said it would run up the coast of South Carolina and turn out to sea, and Robeson County would get a soaking and some wind. Dwight sat in front of the television with his boots on. Glenda filled the bathtub and the big pots with water the way you do and put the flashlights on the kitchen table and went to bed.

The rain started Saturday morning before light and did not stop. It did not rain the way it rains in a summer storm, in bursts, with the sun out between. It came down all at once and steady, so heavy it hissed on the carport roof, so heavy you could not see the barns from the kitchen window, all day, and the wind came up behind it in the afternoon and blew it

sideways, and went on blowing. The power went at four. At dark Dwight put on his rain suit and went out with the big flashlight and stood at the head of the turn row, and the light went out over the field and showed him nothing but rain going sideways through it, silver, and somewhere down below him, under the noise of the wind, a sound he had never heard that field make before, which was the sound of moving water.

He stood there until Glenda came out on the carport in her housecoat and called him in.

The rain stopped some time before morning. When he woke on Sunday the sky was high and blue and washed and the wind was still blowing hard out of the northwest, cool, the first cool day of the fall, and it was so quiet without the power that he could hear the swamp. He went out in his sock feet without his coffee.

The field was gone.

The swamp had come up out of the trees in the night and taken the bottom two-thirds of it, and the water was not black now. It was brown, the brown of the river, moving, with foam on it and whole limbs turning slowly in it, and it stood among the stalks to the height of a man's waist. Where the field still showed above the water at the top, near the road, the wind had gone through it. It had beaten the stalks down flat in the rows, all lying the same way, east, like hair, and stripped them. The cotton was out of the bolls. It was in the mud between the rows in grey wads, beaten in. It was strung along the fence wire by the road in long dirty streamers. It was caught in the ditch, and in the broomsedge, and in the branches of the sweetgums he had not cleared, hanging there like rags. On the bare stalks the empty bolls stood open with nothing in them, brown and curled, like hands.

It looked like a field that somebody had already picked. It looked like the field had been swept.

He stood in the wet grass at the head of the turn row in his sock feet until Glenda came out and took him by the arm.

• • •

The river came up all that day and the next, and by Monday it stood higher at Lumberton than anybody had ever measured it. It went over Interstate 95 and closed it. It came into the water treatment plant and the whole town went dry, twenty thousand people, and trucks came in with bottled water and the churches opened their fellowship halls. It went into South Lumberton and West Lumberton to the eaves of the houses, and people were taken out of their windows in boats, and the people who had boats went in from Pembroke and Prospect and Saddletree in their own johnboats with their own outboards, Indian and Black and white, and carried out whoever was on the roofs. Glenda's sister and her husband came out of their house in South Lumberton in a deer hunter's johnboat with the dog and a garbage bag of clothes and moved into the spare room. The schools closed and did not open again for three weeks. The power came back on Wednesday.

Dwight went to bed on Sunday afternoon and did not get up.

He did not say he was sick. He lay on his side facing the wall with the blinds down, in his clothes, and when Glenda came in he did not turn over. He would not eat. She made him chicken and pastry on the gas stove the way his mother used to make it, with the pastry rolled thin and cut in strips, and set it on the nightstand, and it went cold. On Tuesday Harold came and sat in the chair by the bed for an hour and talked about the river and about the people up and down the state who had drowned in their cars, and Dwight did not answer him, and Harold went out to the kitchen and told Glenda he had seen this before, in men, and it was not good.

What Dwight thought about, lying there, was the girl in the Jeep.

He thought: she has been coming by since the first day. Since I cleared it. Every day. Clearing, disking, bedding, planting, chopping, watching. And I told her, half. I told her I wouldn't sell a bale without her getting hers. Partner. And now there is not one bale. There is not one pound. I promised it and I wanted it and it is in the mud. And he could not tell, lying there, whether what was eating him was the money, or the promise, or the wanting, or something under all three of them that had no name at all, but he could not get up from it, and he could not eat around it.

V. The Kitchen

Thursday, October 13

The mail started running again on Thursday on the roads that were open. The Jeep came down the Prospect road at ten-forty, slow, going around the places where the shoulder had washed out, and it did not stop at the box on the cedar post. It turned in at the turn row and came up the drive and stopped under the carport, and Leanna Oxendine got out of the right-hand side with a bundle of mail held together with a rubber band and knocked on the kitchen door.

Glenda opened it. Her sister was behind her at the stove.

Dwight heard the voice from the back room. He had not been out of the bed in four days, but he heard it, and he knew it, and he said so loud they heard it in the kitchen, the first thing he had said since Sunday.

That's my partner. Bring her in. Give her a seat. Give her some coffee.

They gave her a seat at the kitchen table, in his chair, at the end. They gave her coffee with sugar in it. She sat with the bundle of mail in front of her and her cap on the table and drank some of it.

Where's he at?

He's in the bed, said Glenda. *He's been in the bed since Sunday.*

Go get him, said Leanna Oxendine.

Glenda went back. In a little while Dwight came out of the hall in his sock feet and the clothes he had been lying in for four days, with his hair flat on one side, and sat down at the side of the table, on the bench, where the grandchildren sat.

What's the matter, Mr. Dwight?

He looked at his hands on the oilcloth.

You know what's the matter. You come by here since the day I cleared it. Every day. And I told you, if it makes, you're my partner. I told you half. I wanted to give it to you. He stopped. *I wanted it. I wanted it so bad. And it didn't make. And it's like something's got hold of me. I can't eat. Glenda'll tell you. I can't eat a thing.*

Leanna turned her coffee cup around on the oilcloth.

You know where that comes from? What's got hold of you?

No, he said. *I don't know. But you know. I believe you do.*

She was quiet a while. Glenda's sister had turned off the stove. Out the window, past the carport, you could see the top of the field, the flat stalks, the grey cotton in the mud, the brown water still standing at the bottom with the sky in it.

It comes from wanting, she said. *That's all. The grief comes from it, and the being scared comes from it. You wanted that cotton so bad you lost it before it ever came up out of the ground. You were sitting out there at night with a rifle guarding it from the deer. You were scared every day of your life since March, Mr. Dwight. I saw it on you every morning at that box. You were grieving it before it ever went in the water.*

He looked at her.

Didn't nobody ever tell you that? Grandmama used to make me say it. Every time I cried over something I couldn't have. And she said it to him across the table, plain, the way you would read somebody an address off an envelope.

> *Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee. So that we may boldly say, The Lord is my helper, and I will not fear what man shall do unto me.*
>
> *— Hebrews 13:5–6*

That's the church talking, said Dwight. But he did not say it the way he had said it to the preacher.

Maybe. Leanna drank the rest of her coffee. *I'm just telling you what I know. You can't lose what you're not holding on to. You can't be scared for it either.*

Then she did a thing that Glenda told about for years afterward, at church and at the beauty shop and at Homecoming. She reached across the table and took the bundle of mail out from under the rubber band, and went through it, and took out the envelope from the crop insurance company and the envelope from the Farm Service Agency and the light bill, and laid them face down on the oilcloth in front of him, one, two,

three, the way you would deal cards, and put her hand flat on top of them, and left it there a minute. Then she took her cap and put it on and went out the kitchen door and got in the right-hand side of the Jeep and backed it down the drive.

Dwight sat at the table a long time with his hands on either side of the three envelopes.

Glenda said that what happened next she could not describe, and she had seen people get saved at the altar since she was a girl, and it was not like that. Nobody shouted. He did not cry. He only sat there, and something in his shoulders let go, she said, the way a fist lets go when you sleep, and his face got younger. She said it was like watching somebody set down a sack of feed he had been carrying so long he forgot it was on him.

Then he looked up at her.

Is there any of that chicken and pastry?

VI. The Flag

November

The insurance paid some, the way insurance does. The Farm Service Agency stretched out the note. The government in Raleigh talked about disaster money for farmers and some of it came the next year, and some of it never did. The water went down out of the field by the end of October and left a line of river mud on everything, a foot up the stalks, on the fence posts, on the cedar post that held the mailbox, and a smell that hung in the bottom for weeks.

Dwight went down and walked it in his boots. He did not walk it the way he had in August. He walked it slowly, the way you would walk somebody else's field, and looked at what the river had done, which was a great deal, and what it had not done, which was also a great deal. It had not taken the ground. The ground was still there, black, heavy with silt the river had brought down from Hoke County and Scotland County and laid on it for free. It had not taken the barns. It had not taken the house, or Glenda, or the grandbabies, or Harold, or the deer, which came out of

the swamp at evening as if nothing had happened and browsed the green that was coming up through the mud between the rows.

The cotton was still in the fence. All along the wire by the road the streamers of it hung where the wind had put them, grey from the river, drying white again in the sun, stirring when a truck went by. Nobody had pulled it down. He had meant to. He had stopped meaning to.

He went up the turn row to the box on the cedar post on a Tuesday morning at the end of the month, with frost still in the shade of the ditch. There was nothing to mail. He opened the box and looked inside it and shut it again, and then he reached around and put up the little red flag on the side, the way you do when you want the carrier to stop, and stood there next to it with his hands in his jacket.

At ten-forty the white Jeep came down the Prospect road, slow, stopping and starting, and saw the flag, and stopped.

Leanna Oxendine leaned out of the right-hand window and looked in the empty box, and looked at him.

What you doing, Mr. Dwight?

Standing here, he said.

She nodded. She put the mail in the box, and reached out and put the flag back down, and drove on up the road toward Pembroke, and he stood a while longer by the cedar post with the cotton moving on the wire beside him in the cold wind, white, and the sun coming up over the swamp.

Background

The verse

> *From greed comes grief, from greed comes fear; he who is free from greed knows neither grief nor fear.*
>
> Dhammapada 216, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin farmer who holds wrong views is clearing his field by the river when the Buddha comes by and asks what he is doing. The farmer answers and the Buddha goes on. He comes back day after day, through the plowing, sowing, weeding and guarding, and asks the same question each time. At last the farmer promises him a share: if the crop prospers, he will not eat without giving to him, and

the Buddha will be his partner. The night before the reaping, a great storm beats the crop flat, and the field looks as if it had been cut clean. The farmer takes to his bed and will not eat. The Buddha comes to his door, has him called out, and asks what is wrong; the farmer says the desire of his heart has not been fulfilled. The Buddha asks whether he knows where his grief comes from, and the farmer answers that he does not, but the Buddha knows. Grief and fear, the Buddha says, both come from craving. Read the full commentary story.

Prospect, Robeson County, North Carolina

Robeson County, 2016

The Lumbee take their name from the Lumber River, and most of the tribe's members live in Robeson County, around Pembroke, Prospect and the other communities "on the swamp." North Carolina recognized the tribe in 1885. The Lumbee Act of 1956 named them Indians but withheld federal recognition, and the tribe pursued it in Congress for decades, until the Lumbee Fairness Act was signed in December 2025. Lumbee Homecoming has brought people home to Pembroke every summer since 1968. At the Battle of Hayes Pond in January 1958, several hundred Lumbee broke up a Ku Klux Klan rally near Maxton; two of them carried off the Klan's banner. Like much of eastern North Carolina, Robeson County farmed tobacco under a federal quota until the 2004 buyout, which paid quota holders over ten years. By 2016 cotton growers across the South were fighting Palmer amaranth, a pigweed that had become resistant to glyphosate, and many went back to chopping it by hand.

On September 28, 2016, a stalled storm dropped about ten inches of rain on Robeson and neighboring counties and pushed the Lumber River out of its banks. Ten days later, on October 8, Hurricane Matthew came ashore in South Carolina and dumped another ten to fourteen inches on the same ground. The Lumber River at Lumberton rose to a record of about 24 feet, more than three feet above the old mark. Floodwater shut down sections of Interstate 95 (the U.S. Geological Survey photographed the crossing under water) and reached Lumberton's water treatment plant, leaving more than 22,000 people without running water. Robeson County schools stayed closed

until October 31. Twenty-six people died in North Carolina, and soybeans, sweet potatoes, peanuts and cotton were all caught in the field at the start of harvest.

After the story of a certain Brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 216). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

16.7

Fair Play

And children coming home from school
Look in at the open door.
— Longfellow, "The Village Blacksmith"

This is how I heard it, on North Claiborne Avenue.

I. The Back of the Band

The Tremé, New Orleans · Mardi Gras morning, 1965

The Fair Play Social Aid and Pleasure Club came out of its hall on St. Philip Street at nine o'clock on Mardi Gras morning, the second of March, forty men in lavender suits and straw hats with gold bands, and the Silver Leaf Brass Band behind them, and the grand marshal out in front of everybody.

The grand marshal was Mr. Alcée Gaudet, who had led the Fair Play since 1951 and the rest of the year taught fifth grade at the public school on Columbus Street. He had taught half the children between Esplanade and St. Bernard to do long division and the other half to sit still while the first half did it. On parade days he wore a gold sash over one shoulder with FAIR PLAY sewn on it in purple felt, and carried a gold fan, and he did not say much, in the street or in the classroom. When he lifted the fan, the band began. When he brought it down, the band stopped.

The Silver Leaf was eleven men in white shirts and black pants and black caps with the band's name across the front: three trumpets, two trombones, a clarinet, a tenor saxophone, a tuba, a snare drum and a bass drum. Behind the bass drum, by himself, walked Mr. Casimir Joseph.

Mr. Cass was eighty-one. He had played second trumpet in the brass bands of New Orleans since before the first war, under the lead, holding

the harmony, and in fifty-some years he had never once played the melody or asked to. Three different bands had asked him to lead them, and he had said no all three times. He walked at the back now because he could not keep the pace up front. When he had the breath he played. When he didn't, he carried the horn under his arm like a loaf of bread and kept walking.

He lived in one room over a shoe repair on Marais Street. He went to the six-thirty Mass at St. Augustine every morning, and ate one meal a day, at noon, and shined his own shoes, and would not let a boy carry his horn for him. His band cap had been mended so many times that the gold letters had all been stitched back on by hand, a little crooked. People on Marais Street said Cass Joseph had never told a lie in his life, and the reason was that he had never said enough to tell one. In 1927, when a family on Ursulines could not pay for the band at their boy's funeral, he had put his envelope back into the mother's hand at the gate of the cemetery, and walked home, and never mentioned it, and the band found out from the mother.

II. The Cakes

Claiborne Avenue · late morning

They turned onto Claiborne under the oaks. In 1965 the neutral ground down the middle of North Claiborne Avenue was a long green mile of grass under live oaks whose limbs met over it, and on Mardi Gras the whole Seventh Ward and the Tremé came out and claimed it: ladders for the children to sit on, kitchen chairs, washtubs of ice and beer, chicken in roasting pans, men cooking on halves of oil drums. Somewhere up toward Orleans Avenue the Indians were coming out in their feathers, and you could hear the tambourines before you could see anything.

From the other direction, down the sidewalk, came the children.

It was the Sunday school of the Greater St. Matthew Baptist Church on Galvez Street, and two other churches with it, on their way to the place under the biggest oak where the churches had their spot every year.

There were five hundred of them, people said afterward, though people say a great many things on Mardi Gras. They were carrying the cakes. Pound cakes in dishpans. Tea cakes in shoeboxes. Pralines wrapped in wax paper, in a bushel basket. A king cake from McKenzie's on a board. The big girls carried the dishpans on their heads and the big boys carried the baskets on their shoulders, and the little ones carried one tea cake apiece in both hands as if it were an egg.

When they saw Mr. Gaudet, every one of them said, *Good morning, Mr. Gaudet,* the way they said it in his room on Columbus Street, all together and a little behind each other, and went right on by. They said good morning to Mr. Duplessis, the president of the Fair Play, who was in the funeral business and liked to be greeted, and to the forty men in lavender, and they passed along the band, and not one child said, *Have some cake.*

Mr. Gaudet brought down the fan, and the band stopped.

Anybody here want some cake? he said.

What cake? said the lead trumpet, a young man named Dwight.

You didn't see all those children go by with all that cake?

Mr. Gaudet, those children don't give nobody nothing. They walked right past you, and you taught them.

They didn't offer it to me and they didn't offer it to you, said Mr. Gaudet. *But the man those cakes belong to is walking at the back. We're going to eat some cake before we go on.*

He said it with no bother in his voice. He was not a man who kept accounts against children. He crossed over to the neutral ground and sat down on a root of the big oak, and the Fair Play and the Silver Leaf came after him and sat down on the grass in their good clothes, and the tuba player laid his horn down in the clover like a sleeping dog.

The children were still going along the sidewalk past the end of the band. They came to the bass drum, and passed it, and came to Mr. Cass, walking by himself with his trumpet under his arm and his crooked cap on, and they stopped.

All of them stopped. The ones in front stopped and the ones behind ran into them. Nobody who was there could ever say why. A grown woman who had been one of the little ones told it forty years later and said

it was like when you come into a warm kitchen out of the cold, and that was as close as she could get. The girls took the dishpans down off their heads. The boys set the baskets on the sidewalk. The littlest ones went and put their arms around his legs, and the big boys took off their caps, and a tall girl named Bernadette Pichon held up the king cake on its board with both arms, as high as she could reach.

Have some cake, Mr. Cass.

Mr. Cass looked at all of them for a while, as if he were counting.

Mr. Gaudet and the band are sitting under that tree, he said. *Carry it over there and share it out.*

Yes, sir.

So they picked it all up again, and turned the whole Sunday school around, and went back with him, five hundred children walking slow around one old man so as not to get ahead of him, across Claiborne to the oak. They gave him the first piece of everything. They stood around him in a ring and watched him eat it, a bite of pound cake, a tea cake, a corner of the king cake, the way you watch a person open a present. When he had finished, a boy named Earl went off and came back with a paper cup of water from somebody's jug and held it out with both hands. Then they passed the cakes around to the Silver Leaf and the Fair Play, and to the families on the next ladders over, and to anybody.

III. Fair Play

Under the oak

Mr. Duplessis took his piece of pound cake. He ate it. Then he said, so that the men around him could hear, that he did not call that fair play.

Walked right past the grand marshal of this club. Walked past the president of this club and forty members in good standing. Walked past the whole band. Gave it all to Cass.

That's favoritism, said one of the trombones.

That's what it is, said Mr. Duplessis.

Mr. Gaudet was sitting on his root with his fan across his knees and a tea cake in his hand. He finished the tea cake.

Hilton, he said. *A man like Cass Joseph, the Lord loves him. And everybody on this avenue with any sense loves him too. That's who the children bring the cake to. That's all it is.* He looked over at the ring of children, who had gone quiet, the way a class goes quiet when it knows what's coming. *Every one of you stood up in my room and said it. Who remembers*?

Bernadette Pichon remembered, and then they all did, the way they had said it in fifth grade, all together and a little behind each other, under the oak on Claiborne Avenue with the tambourines coming down from Orleans:

> *His brow is wet with honest sweat,*
> *He earns whate'er he can,*
> *And looks the whole world in the face,*
> *For he owes not any man.*
>
> *And children coming home from school*
> *Look in at the open door;*
> *They love to see the flaming forge,*
> *And hear the bellows roar,*
> *And catch the burning sparks that fly*
> *Like chaff from a threshing-floor.*
>
> *Toiling,—rejoicing,—sorrowing,*
> *Onward through life he goes;*
> *Each morning sees some task begin,*
> *Each evening sees it close;*
> *Something attempted, something done,*
> *Has earned a night's repose.*
>
> *— Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, "The Village Blacksmith" (1840)*

Mr. Cass sat on the grass with his horn across his lap and the paper cup in his hand, and did not look as if any of it had anything to do with him.

Mr. Duplessis said, after a while, that he supposed that was so.

The children did not go on to their spot. They stayed with the Silver Leaf the rest of the day, all the way up Claiborne and back, carrying what was left of the cakes, and when the band played, the ones who had been in Mr. Gaudet's room walked closest to Mr. Cass, and when he had no breath to play they walked beside him and kept time. Whatever it was that happened to them under the oak, the people who were children there will tell you it took. Bernadette Pichon taught school for thirty-six years. Earl Lavigne, the boy with the cup, took up the trumpet that summer and played second in the Silver Leaf until the band broke up, under the lead, holding the harmony, and never once asked for the melody.

IV. The Columns

North Claiborne Avenue · 1966–1968

The next year the state came with saws and began taking down the oaks for the expressway. People stood on the neutral ground and watched it, and some of them cried, and it made no difference. Mr. Cass died in the spring of 1967, and the Silver Leaf played him to St. Louis Number Two with the dirge going so slow that the bass drum seemed to stop between every beat, and Mr. Gaudet walked in front in his sash with the fan held down, and five hundred people came behind who had been children, or said they had.

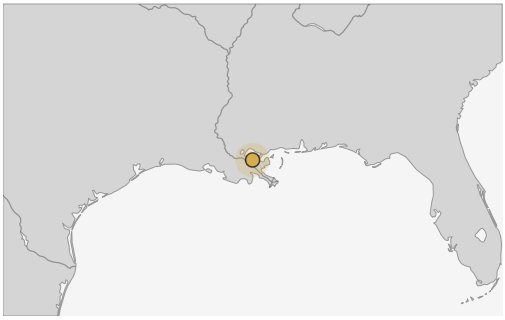
The big oak came down in 1968. Where it stood there is a concrete column now, holding up the interstate. On Mardi Gras the families still bring their ladders and their chairs and set them up on the neutral ground between the columns, in the shade of the highway, and the trucks go over all day like weather. And somebody always brings a cake, and cuts the first piece, and stands at the edge of the sidewalk holding it out for whoever is walking last.

Background

The verse

> *He who possesses virtue and intelligence, who is just, speaks the truth, and does what is his own business, him the world will hold dear.*
>
> Dhammapada 217, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, on a festival day, the Buddha enters Rājagaha for alms with the eighty great elders and five hundred monks, and meets five hundred youths carrying baskets of cakes out to a pleasure garden. They greet him and go on without offering a single monk a cake. The Buddha says the owner of the cakes is walking at the rear, and they will eat before they go on, and he sits down with the monks under a tree. At the sight of the elder Mahā Kassapa, walking last, the youths are filled with joy; they set down their baskets, bow to him and offer him everything. He sends them back to share it with the Buddha and the Saṅgha. They serve him, watch him eat, and give him water. The monks complain of favoritism, and the Buddha answers that a monk like Kassapa is dear to gods and humans alike, and speaks the verse; the youths are established in the first fruit of the path. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa, the austere elder who later led the First Council.



New Orleans, Louisiana

North Claiborne Avenue, *1965*

New Orleans's Black benevolent societies, first organized by free Creoles of color in the early 1800s and multiplied after the Civil War, paid members' medical and burial costs and hired brass bands for funerals and parades; their successors, the social aid and pleasure clubs, still parade their neighborhoods with a brass band and the "second line" of followers behind it (64 Parishes). A traditional brass band of the period was typically trumpets, trombones, a clarinet or saxophone, tuba, snare and bass drum, as in the Eureka Brass Band. Mr. Cass goes to Mass at St. Augustine

Church in the Tremé, founded by free people of color in 1841 and said to be the oldest Black Catholic parish in the United States.

The wide neutral ground of North Claiborne Avenue, shaded by live oaks, was the promenade and picnic ground of Black New Orleans and the heart of its Carnival, where clubs, Mardi Gras Indians and Baby Dolls paraded. In 1966 officials decided, over residents' protests, to uproot the oaks and run the elevated Interstate 10 expressway down the avenue; the trees came out in the late 1960s, and concrete columns stand where they grew (A Closer Walk; Smithsonian). Longfellow's "The Village Blacksmith," first published in 1840, was a schoolroom recitation piece for a century; the text here follows *Poems That Every Child Should Know* (1904).

After the story of the five hundred youths and the elder Mahā Kassapa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 217). The original. Verse from Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's "The Village Blacksmith" (1840), as printed in *Poems That Every Child Should Know* (1904). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

16.8

White River

> *I do not say that I have already won the race or have already reached perfection.*
> *— Philippians 3:12*

Here is how it was told, in the kitchens on Jackson Street.

I. The Boarder

Muncie, Indiana · November 1924

The Keevers took a boarder that fall for the money, the way half of Jackson Street did, and because Mrs. Keever's husband had been dead four years and the house had a front bedroom nobody slept in. The boarder was a Miss Agnes Thayer from New York. She was twenty-six and wore her hair bobbed and her skirts at the shin, and she came with the people from Columbia University who were studying the town.

Nobody on Jackson Street could make out what there was to study. Muncie was Muncie. It had the Ball jar works and the Warner Gear and the wire mill and forty-some churches, and it had had gas once, when the boom was on, enough to burn flambeaux on the street corners day and night, and then the gas ran out and the jar works stayed. In the summer the Klan had paraded down Walnut Street in their robes, and a good many men from the churches had marched in it. But the people from Columbia were all over town that winter with notebooks. They sat in the back of the churches and the Rotary lunches. They went into the kitchens of the wives of men at the Ball works and the wives of men at the bank and asked them what time they got up, how often they washed, whether they had a bathtub, what they read, how much the car had cost.

Mrs. Keever said if a woman came into her kitchen and asked her how often she washed she would tell her Monday, the same as God intended, and show her the door.

But Miss Thayer paid four dollars a week in advance and made her own bed, and Mrs. Keever came round to her.

Her father was a Congregational minister in Rutland, Vermont. She said it at supper the first night, the way a person says where they were born, and did not say anything else about it, and she did not go to church on Sundays except for the work, when she sat in the back and wrote. She kept a little blue Weymouth Testament on her dresser anyway. Mrs. Keever saw it when she changed the towels.

There was one other person in the house, and that was Grandfather Keever.

He was eighty-one. He had been a Methodist Episcopal preacher in the North Indiana Conference for forty-four years, on circuits in Jay County and Randolph County and Delaware County, and had married some of the fathers of the men now running the town and buried most of their grandfathers. He had been superannuated since 1912. He lived in the back bedroom off the kitchen, over the cistern, because the stairs were too much for him. He had not gone downtown to see the Klan go by. He was thin and very clean and very quiet, and he read his Bible and the Indianapolis Star, and every morning of the year, unless there was ice, he walked out to the White River and along it upstream as far as the Walnut Street bridge and back.

Miss Thayer had a list of old people she was supposed to see, to find out what the town had been like in 1890. He was on it. She took her notebook back to his room after supper and they talked by the stove for six evenings in November, about the revivals of the eighties and the gas boom, about the class meetings and the love feasts and the little printed tickets the class leader used to hand out each quarter to show you were in good standing, which nobody gave anymore. He kept his in a White Owl cigar box, sixty years of them. He let her see them.

II. The Question

Jackson Street · Christmas 1924

Paul Keever came home from Taylor University for Christmas, and he brought his roommate, Harold Tull, from up by Fort Wayne, whose people could not have him that year.

Taylor was a holiness college up in Upland, an hour north, Methodist in everything but the deed, and the old holiness was still strong there. The boys had been to the meetings that fall. They had gone to the altar, both of them, and come away believing they had been sanctified wholly, that the second blessing had been given and the root of sin taken out of them. They talked about it at supper, Paul with his ears red and Harold steadily, and Mrs. Keever said that was very nice and passed the potatoes.

On Christmas afternoon, while she did the dishes and Miss Thayer dried, the boys went back to the old man's room and asked him.

It was a fair question among Methodists. It had been put to him once, in public, when he was a young man standing before the bishop to be taken into full connection, in the words Mr. Wesley had written: *Are you going on to perfection? Do you expect to be made perfect in love in this life?* He had said yes and yes. Now his grandson stood in front of him with a Taylor pennant on the wall behind him and asked him the next thing.

Grandfather, have you received it? Are you made perfect in love?

The old man looked at them a long time. Then he looked at the stove.

He was thinking of Mother Lykins. She had been in his Albany class in 1874. She took in washing for the railroad men and could not read, and she had stood up at a love feast in a brush arbor with her red hands folded and said that God had taken everything out of her heart but love, and nobody in that arbor doubted it, and nobody who knew her afterward ever had cause to. There had been a good many like her on his circuits. Women mostly. A hired man in Randolph County. A girl of fourteen who died of the lung fever. People who had it plain and said so in four words and went back to the wash.

What was there in that for a preacher to make a speech about? Any washerwoman in Albany had it. A man who had been forty-four years in

the ministry ought to have something more to show before he stood up and talked about himself. Mr. Wesley had said there was no perfection in this life that did not admit of a continual increase. Let him get farther along. When he was finished, he would tell them.

So he said nothing. He was shy of it, the way an old man is shy of a new suit.

After a while Harold said, *Well,* and Paul said, *Yes sir,* and they went out, and he heard them on the back porch talking low, and then he heard them go off down the street toward Walnut to see the pictures.

III. Upstream

The White River · February 1925

He took cold in the middle of January, walking. The river was open in the middle and shelved with ice along the banks, and he went out anyway, as far as the bridge, and came back with his face grey. Dr. Bowles came twice. It went into his chest the first week of February, and on the night of the eleventh, with Mrs. Keever on one side of the bed and Miss Thayer on the other, because Miss Thayer had been sitting up with him nights and would not let anyone else take her turn, he died.

He did not say anything at the end. He looked at the window and breathed out and that was all.

They buried him from High Street. The church was full of old people from the country who had driven in on the frozen roads in Model T's and in a few buggies, and men from the Ball works who had been married by him, and the district superintendent preached, and the choir sang O for a heart to praise my God. Paul and Harold came down on the train. They sat in the front pew with Mrs. Keever and wept through the whole of it, and that night, in the kitchen, they were weeping still.

Mrs. Keever told them to stop it. *He was eighty-one,* she said. *He was ready. Everybody knew it was coming.*

We know that, Paul said. *That isn't it.*

It isn't that he died, Harold said. *We asked him. At Christmas we asked him plain if he had it, and he never said. He never said one word. Now he's gone and we'll never know if he got there.*

They sat at the kitchen table with their faces in their hands, the two young men who had been sanctified wholly that fall, and wept because an old man had kept quiet.

IV. The Card

Jackson Street · that night

Miss Thayer had been standing in the door of the front room. She came in and sat down at the table with them.

She had a white card in her hand, a five-by-eight from the study, ruled, with the old man's name at the top in her small upright hand. She laid it in front of Paul and put her finger on a line near the bottom.

There's a question I ask every woman I sit with, she said. *I've asked it of a hundred and some women in this town. If you had more money, what would you buy? I asked him too, the last night in November. It wasn't on his schedule. I just asked.*

Paul looked. Every woman in Muncie had answered it, she said, and she could tell him what they had said without looking, because they had all said the same things. A car, if they had none. A better car, if they had one. A bathroom. A washing machine. A radio. A house on the north side. Shoes for the children. Not one of them had said nothing.

On his card, after the question, she had written one word and underlined it. *Nothing.*

He thought about it a long time, she said. *He said he was trying to be fair to me. Then he said he couldn't think of a thing.*

She took the card back.

You asked him if he had it, she said. *I'm not a Methodist, and I'm not anything anymore. But I was raised in a parsonage, and I can tell you why he didn't answer. My father was the same. It's the preachers who won't say it. They're ashamed to have only what the washerwomen have.*

He had it, she said. *You only had to look at him.*

And then, because she was a minister's daughter after all, and because it was the only way she knew to say the rest of it, she went upstairs and came back down with the little blue Weymouth and read them two places, standing by the stove where the old man used to sit.

> *Give your minds to the things that are above, not to the things that are on the earth. For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God.*
>
> *— Colossians 3:2–3*
>
> *I do not say that I have already won the race or have already reached perfection. But I am pressing on, striving to lay hold of the prize for which also Christ has laid hold of me. Brethren, I do not imagine that I have yet laid hold of it. But this one thing I do—forgetting everything which is past and stretching forward to what lies in front of me, with my eyes fixed on the goal I push on to secure the prize of God's heavenward call in Christ Jesus.*
>
> *— Philippians 3:12–14*

He was still going, she said. *That's all. He hadn't stopped to tell anybody.*

She shut the book. Mrs. Keever had put her dishrag down. The boys sat a long time without saying anything, and the clock on the kitchen shelf went on, and neither of them was weeping anymore. Harold said afterward, when he had a church of his own in Kokomo and was asked about that night, that he had come into the Keevers' kitchen sanctified and gone out of it a Christian, and he did not care to explain the difference.

V. The Tickets

The White River · March 1925

Miss Thayer went back to New York in the summer, when the study was done. She sent Mrs. Keever a Christmas card for several years from an address on Morningside Heights, and then the cards

stopped. The book came out in 1929. Paul looked in it for his grandfather, and he was not in it, and Paul thought that was about right.

The White Owl box came to Paul. Inside were the class tickets, sixty years of them, small as playing cards, each with the quarter and the year and a verse printed on it, and the name of the class leader in ink. The oldest was for the first quarter of 1864, and the newest was for the last year anyone on his circuits still gave them out. Under them, at the bottom of the box, folded once, was the paper of his ordination questions, with no mark on it anywhere to show what he thought.

The ice went out of the White River the third week in March. Paul came down from Upland on a Saturday and walked out along the bank in the morning, upstream, the way the old man had gone every day, against the water. Big plates of it came down past him, grey, turning slowly, knocking against the piers of the Walnut Street bridge and going on under. He went as far as the bridge. Then, because there was no reason to stop there except that his grandfather always had, he went on.

Background

The verse

> *He in whom a desire for the Ineffable (Nirvana) has sprung up, who is satisfied in his mind, and whose thoughts are not bewildered by love, he is called urdhvamsrotas (carried upwards by the stream).*
>
> Dhammapada 218, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

An elder monk has reached the third stage of awakening, that of the non-returner, who has cut off sensual desire and will not be born into this world again. When the monks who live with him ask whether he has attained anything, he says nothing, from embarrassment: even laypeople reach that stage, and he means to speak only once he is fully awakened. He dies first, and is reborn in the Pure Abodes, from which non-returners pass on to final release. His pupils weep, not because he died but because he never answered them. The Buddha tells them their teacher had freed his heart from sensual desire, and speaks of one who has "gone upstream." Read the full commentary story, or about the non-returner.

Muncie, Indiana

Muncie, Indiana, 1924–25

In January 1924 Robert and Helen Lynd and a small team of researchers began studying Muncie as a typical American small city, through documents, old newspapers, surveys and interviews. Their book, *Middletown* (1929), never named the town. It found 42 churches of 28 denominations, with the Methodist church the most prestigious, and described the line between the working class and the business class as the town's deepest division. Muncie had grown on the Indiana gas boom of the 1880s, which brought Ball Brothers and their glass fruit jars in 1888; the Ku Klux Klan, strong in the town early in the decade, held parades there in 1922 and 1924. Miss Thayer, the Keevers and everyone else in the story are invented.

John Wesley taught that a believer could be made perfect in love in this life, and Methodist preachers are still asked at ordination whether they are "going on to perfection" and expect to be made perfect in love. The nineteenth-century Holiness movement made this "entire sanctification" or "second blessing" an instantaneous experience received by faith, often at the altar of a camp meeting. Taylor University in Upland, founded by Methodists, moved there in 1893 and ended its formal tie to the Methodist church in 1922. The verses are from Richard Francis Weymouth's New Testament in Modern Speech, first published in 1903.

After the story of the elder who was a non-returner from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 218). The original. Scripture from the Weymouth New Testament in Modern Speech (1903). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

16.9

Everlasting Cottages

> *But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him.*
> *— Luke 15:20*

The way it was told, in Walnut Creek Township.

I. Church at Our House

Walnut Creek Township, Holmes County, Ohio · spring 1993

Noah Troyer was the kind of young man the old women pointed out to their daughters. He joined church at nineteen without being told twice. He sang the slow hymns from the Ausbund in a voice that held the long notes as steady as a level. When church was at somebody else's house he went over the night before to help unload the bench wagon, and when it was at his father's he scrubbed the shop floor himself so the men's horses would have a clean place to stand in the rain.

His mother was Fannie Troyer, and across the township road lived her cousin's family, the Hershbergers, and their daughter Rebecca. Both mothers had settled long ago, over a quilt frame, that Noah and Rebecca would make a pair. Noah did not want her.

Rebecca was twenty-two and had not joined church. She worked at a tourist restaurant in Berlin, carrying plates of broasted chicken to people from Cleveland, and she kept her tips in a coffee can and did not tell her father how much was in it. When the deacon came by with the alms list she was always upstairs. When a peddler or a man walking to Florida knocked at the Hershbergers' back door, it was never Rebecca who gave him bread. She was quick and good-looking and she laughed at the

wrong people, and Noah said to his mother that he could not marry a girl who had never once given anything away.

Fannie went across the road.

Church is at our place in three weeks, she told Rebecca. *Come help me get ready for it. Scrub the walls and the windows. Help the boys set up the benches. When the ministers come in, take their hats and hang them on the nails. Keep their water glasses full, and when they've eaten, wash up the cups and the dishes and put them back in the bench wagon the way they came. If you do it, you'll win him.*

Rebecca came. She came every evening for a week. She stood on a chair and washed the kitchen ceiling with ammonia water. She carried benches with the Troyer boys and set them in rows in the shop, and laid the bench extenders across them for the noon tables. On the Sunday she stood at the door in a white cape and took the black hats of the bishop and the two ministers and the deacon as they came in out of the rain and hung each one on its nail. She kept their glasses full through the long first sermon and the second. At noon she carried the peanut butter spread and the red beets and the bread down the tables. In the afternoon she washed two hundred cups.

Fannie watched all of it. That night she said to Noah, *She takes correction now.*

Rebecca was baptized in the fall. They were married on a Thursday in December, in the Hershbergers' barn, and the cooks served roasht and mashed potatoes to three hundred people. That night, when the last of the cousins had gone home, Noah said to his wife, plainly, the way he said everything: *If you'll take care of the church and my mam and dat, you can live in that house as long as you like. Be careful with it.*

All right, said Rebecca.

II. The Pallet Shop

State Route 515 · 1994–2015

She kept the promise. In a few years nobody remembered that she had once been the girl upstairs when the deacon came. She was

THE FIRST ONE THERE WHEN A BARN BURNED AND THE FIRST one home from a funeral to start the coffee. She bore two boys, Eli and Mose, and she nursed Noah's father through his last two years when his lungs went, and carried his mother's meals up the stairs until his mother died too. Then she was mistress of the Troyer place, and Noah was a rich man.

Old Eli Troyer had started with a sawmill. Noah built it into a pallet shop that ran two shifts, then a shop that made porch furniture for the tourist stores along Route 39, and then, because the Amish of Holmes County were building faster than they could find carpenters, a crew that put up pole barns from Wooster to Coshocton. He did not have a telephone in the house, but there was one in a shanty at the end of the lane that rang all day.

He gave. He gave to the alms fund until the deacon told him to stop because people would talk. And he put a long table in the break room at the shop, with an urn of coffee and a slow cooker, and he told anyone who asked that it was for the drivers.

The drivers were the English people, and a few who were not quite English, who drove the Amish wherever a buggy could not go: to the hospital in Akron, to a funeral in Indiana, to the dentist, to a wedding in Wisconsin. They charged by the mile and they waited. They waited in parking lots and hospital lobbies and at the ends of lanes, sometimes all day, and at Amish funerals, where there might be eighty vans in a hayfield, they ate their dinner in their seats, handed to them through the windows. Noah's table was the one place in the county where a driver could come in, sit down with a plate and be fed like company. Truckers who had lost their way found it too, and a man walking from Maine to Key West with a dog, and once a busload of Chinese tourists who were looking for the cheese house. Rebecca kept the slow cooker filled, and on Saturdays she baked for it.

III. The Driver

Interstate 75, southbound · January 2016

Sadie Mast had grown up Amish on Township Road 606 and left at eighteen, the year before she would have joined church, and because she had never been baptized she had never been put out. She could still go to her mother's for Sunday dinner. She still talked to her passengers in Deitsch, which made the old ones easy with her and the young ones careful. She had been driving for twenty-two years in a white fifteen-passenger Ford with a hundred and ninety thousand miles on it, and she had driven most of Walnut Creek Township to most of its funerals. She was fifty-four. She did not talk much. She listened to the radio low, gospel or the farm report, and switched it off when the old people prayed.

In January of 2016 Noah hired her to drive him and Rebecca down to Pinecraft for two weeks, because his back had gone out and he could not sit for twenty hours on the bus. Somewhere in Georgia, after dark, with Rebecca asleep on the back bench, he moved up to the seat behind Sadie and they talked.

He asked her about Pinecraft, because she had been driving people down there for years. She told him what she had seen. The little white cottages on Kauffman and Graber and Yoder streets, rented a year ahead. The shuffleboard courts in the park where the old men played three games and went to the back of the list. The Pioneer Trails bus coming in at the Tourist Church across from the post office, and the crowd that came out to meet it.

Who goes down? Noah asked.

Whoever can pay for it, Sadie said. Then, after a mile: *Abe Weaver never has.*

Abe Weaver was the bishop of Noah's district. He was eighty-one. The lot had fallen on him at thirty-four, when he was a young dairyman with six children, and for forty-seven years he had preached and married and buried and gone to sit with the dying, every week, for nothing, because

Amish ministers are paid nothing, and he had milked thirty cows twice a day besides. He had never seen the ocean.

There's a lot of them like that, Sadie said. *The ministers. They say yes to God at the lot and that's it, that's their life. They spend it on everybody else. They don't get a winter.* She was quiet a while. *The ones who give the most get the least of anything you can hold in your hand. You'd think it would work out the other way.*

That was all she said. Noah sat behind her watching the white lines come up out of the dark, and by the Florida line he had decided.

IV. Four Rooms

Pinecraft, Sarasota, Florida · January 2017

He bought a lot on Schrock Street with a tired cinderblock bungalow on it and had his own crew drive down in two vans and take it to the slab. On the slab they built a cottage with four bedrooms opening off a long screened porch, so four couples could have their own doors, and a kitchen big enough for all of them, and a shed for the tricycles. He had beds made in his own shop, oak, with rope springs for the old ones who said modern springs hurt their backs. He had rockers made for the porch. Then he went to the bishop's council and gave the whole thing to the ministers of the Walnut Creek districts and their wives, to be used in turn, every winter, for as long as there were ministers.

The Amish do not dedicate buildings. There was no ceremony. Sadie drove the first four couples down herself in January, Abe Weaver among them, in his Sunday coat, and she was there when Noah walked them through it.

The old bishop stood on the porch and looked at the four doors for a long time and could not say anything. His wife sat down in a rocker and wept and laughed at herself for weeping.

Noah wanted to show them the water. The well man had put in a new line from the street that week, and an outside spigot by the porch steps for washing sand off feet. Noah turned the handle and the pipe coughed

and spat air and then ran clear. He looked around for something to catch it in to show them it was clean, and there was nothing, and Sadie was standing closest.

Hold out your hand, he said.

She held out her right hand, cupped, the way you hold it at a pump. He ran the water into it until it spilled over her fingers onto the white sand.

Cold, Sadie said, surprised. It was eighty degrees.

V. What Mose Saw

Sarasota Memorial Hospital and the road north · February 2018

Mose Raber was one of the two ministers in Noah's district, a lean, quiet harness-maker of seventy-three who had been to Pinecraft once before in his life. He was in the cottage on Schrock Street with his wife the next winter when his heart stopped on the shuffleboard court.

A retired fireman from Indiana, a Mennonite, worked on him on the concrete until the ambulance came. At the hospital they said his heart had not beaten for six minutes. He came back on the second day and lay in the bed with the tubes in his arms, and when his wife had gone down to the cafeteria he told the night nurse, a Haitian woman who listened to him as if he were telling her the weather, where he had been.

He had been standing outside a house. It was white and so large he could not see where it ended in any direction, larger than all of Holmes County, and it went up until he could not see the top, and every board of it shone like the inside of a shell. There were flowers in the air in front of the door, pink and red, as if somebody had thrown a double handful of them up in the air and they had forgot to come down. At every window there were women in white, more than he could count, in white capes and white coverings like a wedding, and they came down to him on the steps.

Whose house is this? Mose asked them.

Noah Troyer's, they said. *From Walnut Creek. He gave a house to the ministers, and this house came up the same minute. We're waiting for him. We are so*

lonesome for him we can hardly stand it. Tell him to come. Tell him leaving there for here is like breaking a cracked crock and getting a silver pitcher.

Then the women were gone and he was on the shuffleboard court with a stranger's mouth on his.

He could not ride the bus home after that, so his sons hired Sadie Mast to come down and drive him. On the second night, north of Valdosta, with his wife asleep behind him, Mose leaned forward in the dark and told Sadie the whole thing, because people tell drivers everything, and when he had told it he asked her what he had been wanting to ask someone.

Sadie. Is it true? That what a man does here is built for him there, while he's still living?

Sadie drove for a while. A truck went by with its windows lit like a kitchen.

Mose, she said. *You were there. You saw it. Why are you asking me?*

Then it's true.

You know the bus, she said. *At Pinecraft.*

He knew it. Mondays and Wednesdays and Fridays in the busy months, the Pioneer Trails bus from Millersburg came in at the Tourist Church lot after twenty-some hours on the road. A hundred people would be waiting there for it in the sun who had no one on it, just to see. And somebody always saw it first, some boy on a tricycle out at the corner of Bahia Vista, and came pedaling back hollering, *It's here, it's here,* and if he knew who was on it he hollered the names. The old men left their games on the shuffleboard court. The women came out of the cottages drying their hands. When the door opened and the first passenger came down the deep steps holding the rail, they all pressed in to get to him, to shake his hand, to take his suitcase. You came all this way. You made it. Let me. No, let me.

It's like that, Sadie said. *Somebody who's been gone a long time comes up the road, and whoever sees him first runs to tell. And they all come out. It's like that when somebody who did good goes over. What he did is standing in the lot waiting for him. It's all pushing up to the bus. Me first.* She was quiet a mile. *My grossmammi used to say it out of the German Bible. The father who ran.*

And she said it, first the way they had both heard it all their lives in church, and then in English.

> *Und er machte sich auf und kam zu seinem Vater. Da er aber noch ferne von dannen war, sah ihn sein Vater, und es jammerte ihn, lief und fiel ihm um seinen Hals und küßte ihn.*
>
> *And he arose, and came to his father. But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him.*
>
> *— Luke 15:20*

Mose sat back. After a while he said, *And the other one. In the next chapter. About the friends.*

Sadie said that too.

> *Und ich sage euch auch: Machet euch Freunde mit dem ungerechten Mammon, auf daß, wenn ihr nun darbet, sie euch aufnehmen in die ewigen Hütten.*
>
> *And I say unto you, Make to yourselves friends of the mammon of unrighteousness; that, when ye fail, they may receive you into everlasting habitations.*
>
> *— Luke 16:9*

In die ewigen Hütten, said Mose. *The everlasting cottages.* He laughed for the first time since the shuffleboard court, very quietly so as not to wake his wife, and then he slept all the way to Chattanooga.

He told Noah, in the spring, sitting on a bench outside the harness shop. Noah listened, and thanked him, and told no one, and went on as before. He doubled the alms. He kept the drivers' table. He was fifty-three that year and stronger than any man on his crews.

VI. Rebecca

Walnut Creek Township · 2021–2023

Noah Troyer died in October of 2021 on the floor of his own pallet shop, at fifty-six, between one board and the next. They buried him on a Saturday in the Troyer graveyard on the hill behind the house, and there were a hundred and forty vans in the hayfield. The drivers ate standing up at his table in the break room, which was still set, because nobody had thought to tell Rebecca not to.

She told them after that. In November she unplugged the slow cooker and took it to the house and had the table carried out to the scrap pile behind the shop. When a driver came in out of the rain in December looking for coffee she told him the shop was a business. She told the deacon the alms would be what the Ordnung asked and not a dollar over. When it came the Troyers' turn for church that spring, she sent word to the bishop that it would have to be at somebody else's house, she was not running a hotel for preachers. And she went to the bishop's council with an English lawyer from Millersburg about getting back the cottage on Schrock Street, which was hers, she said, by rights, and her sons'.

Her sons were grown and married and lived down the road and did not know what to do with her. Nobody did. People said she had never really been converted. People said it was grief, that grief turns some people to water and some to stone. People said that Noah had held her the way a hand holds a bucket under a spring, and when the hand was gone the bucket was a bucket. All of it was probably true.

What happened next is told in Walnut Creek in more than one way.

Her daughter-in-law was staying with her that winter, and it is her telling that most people go by. Rebecca came to her bed in the night in February, shaking, and said that two men had knocked at the kitchen door. They were dressed for church, in black, but she did not know them, and they would not come in. They had taken her by the arms and walked her out the lane, and the lane had not ended at the road. It had gone on and on, and at the end of it they had shown her a white house so big she could not see the ends of it, with flowers hanging in the air before the

door and women in white at all the windows, and she had known whose house it was. And then they had turned her around and shown her the other place, the one that had been got ready for her. She would not say what it was like. She said only that it was made out of everything she had kept.

In the morning she could not speak. The stroke had taken her right side and all her words.

She lived. She lay in a hospital bed in the front room of the Troyer house for the next two years and more, with her eyes open, looking at something in the corner of the ceiling that no one else could see. Whatever it was, she did not look away from it, and her face when she looked at it was the hardest thing anyone in that house had ever had to watch.

The church took care of her. That is the part no one tells differently. The women of the district sat with her in shifts, day and night, the way Amish women sit with the sick, and fed her with a spoon, and turned her, and sang to her out of the Ausbund. Mose Raber's wife came on Tuesdays. Abe Weaver came on Sundays until he died. The women who lived too far to come by buggy hired a driver, and most often the driver was Sadie Mast, who would not take money for it, and who sat in the van in the lane for the four hours with the radio off.

VII. The Bus

Pinecraft · February 2023

Sadie drove three of the couples down again that winter, as she had every winter since the first. The cottage on Schrock Street had held a hundred and four ministers and their wives by then. Mose Raber's wife kept the count in the back of the guest book. The beds had not squeaked once. The rockers had worn two pale arcs in the porch boards.

The fourth couple came by bus. In the fall the lot had fallen on Eli Troyer, Noah's older son, who was twenty-eight and ran the pallet shop and had two babies, and who had stood up white in the face in the Raber

barn when the bishop opened the hymnbook in front of him and found the slip of paper. He had never been to Florida. His mother lay in the front room at home with her eyes on the corner of the ceiling, and his brother's wife was sitting with her, and he had not wanted to go. The bishop had told him to go.

On the Wednesday Sadie walked over to the Tourist Church lot at three o'clock. A boy on a red tricycle came tearing back from Bahia Vista standing up on the pedals. *It's here!* The old men laid their cues across the shuffleboard courts. A hundred people came out into the sun. The bus turned in across from the post office and sighed down onto its springs. The door opened. Eli Troyer came down the deep steps in his black hat, holding the rail with one hand and a baby with the other, and the boy on the tricycle hollered his name, and the whole lot pressed toward him at once, everyone wanting to be first to take his suitcase.

Sadie stood at the back of the crowd and let them.

When she walked back to the cottage the four old couples were all out on the porch in the rockers, and somebody had hung a tin cup on a nail over the spigot by the steps. Sadie filled it, and drank, and it was still cold.

Background

The verses

> *Kinsmen, friends, and lovers salute a man who has been long away, and returns safe from afar.*
>
> Dhammapada 219, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *In like manner his good works receive him who has done good, and has gone from this world to the other;—as kinsmen receive a friend on his return.*
>
> Dhammapada 220, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Nandiya is a devout young man of Bārāṇasī whose parents want him to marry his cousin Revatī, who does not believe and never gives alms. His mother sets her a test: get the house ready for the monks, prepare their seats, take their bowls, strain their water and wash up after them. Revatī does it and they marry. She becomes devout, bears two sons and runs the household when his parents die.

Nandiya, now rich, feeds the monks, the poor and travelers at his door, and gives the order a four-chambered hall at Isipatana. As he pours the water of donation into the Buddha's right hand, a jeweled mansion rises for him in the heaven of the Thirty-Three. The elder Moggallāna sees it on a visit there, and the heavenly women in it beg him to tell Nandiya to come. When Moggallāna asks whether such rewards come while a man still lives, the Buddha answers that he has seen it himself, and compares the welcome of the good in the next world to kinsmen running out to meet one who comes home from far away. The commentary to the Vimānavatthu adds that after Nandiya died, Revatī stopped the alms, abused the monks and was cast alive into hell. Read the full commentary story.

Walnut Creek Township, Holmes County, Ohio

Holmes County and Pinecraft, 1993-2023

Holmes County and the counties around it hold one of the largest Amish settlements in the world, about 39,000 people in 2025. Old Order Amish worship every other Sunday in a member's home or barn, on benches carried from house to house in a bench wagon. The host family spends a week scrubbing walls and windows and serves a plain noon meal of bread, peanut butter spread, pickles and red beets (how a house gets ready for church). They sing from the Ausbund, first printed in 1564. Bishops, ministers and deacons are nominated by the members and then chosen by lot, by drawing hymnbooks until one turns up a hidden slip with a Bible verse. They have no formal training, they serve without pay, normally for life, and support themselves at their own work. Baptism is required before marriage, and only baptized members can be shunned, so a young person who leaves before joining church is not put out. In Holmes County most weddings fall on Thursdays, and they were once clustered in the winter months (Holmes County wedding customs). For trips a buggy cannot make, the Amish hire drivers by the mile, and those drivers spend much of their lives waiting in vans (a driver's account).

Pinecraft, a neighborhood of small cottages in Sarasota, took its name in 1925–26 from a tourist camp. It became the winter village of Amish and Mennonites from

across North America, with the Mennonite Tourist Church on Bahia Vista Street, bought in 1946, as its landmark. The Pioneer Trails line of Millersburg, Ohio, runs buses down from Holmes County and the other northern settlements. In the busy months a crowd of a hundred or so gathers in the church lot across from the little post office to watch each bus come in, and the welcomes are over in about fifteen minutes (when the bus comes in). In the park the old men play shuffleboard by sign-up list, and adult tricycles take the place of buggies (Pioneer Trails to Pinecraft).

After the story of Nandiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 219 and 220). The original. Scripture from the Luther Bible (1912) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 17

Anger

17.1

Cowhage

> *Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice.*
> *— Ephesians 4:31*

I would like to testify, at Manitou.

I. The Veil

Colorado Springs · June 1904

Frank Weller came home to the Springs in the middle of June, eight days after the depot at Independence was blown up. The whole district was still full of it. Thirteen men going on night shift at the Findley had been killed on the platform by a charge of dynamite under the boards, and in the days after it the mine owners and the militia had cleared every union man they could find out of the camp, and put them in bullpens, and loaded them onto trains and dumped them across the state line. On the porches of the North End people talked about nothing else. The word that came up most was *hang*.

Frank had been gone four years. He had gone east to be a mining engineer and come back a Christian Scientist, which his father, who owned a third of a good mine above Victor, took about as well as he would have taken a cave-in. He had been taught in a class in Boston and had practiced for two years in Denver, and he came down on the noon train with a party of eleven Scientists from the Denver churches who wanted to see the Peak, and the whole family went down to the Antlers to meet him. His father went, and his stepmother, and two uncles, and their wives, and a crowd of cousins. Everyone went but his sister.

Where's Rowena?

At home.

Why didn't she come?

His stepmother lowered her voice, though there was nobody in the lobby of the Antlers who did not already know. *Her skin is very bad again. She won't go out. She's ashamed to.*

Send for her, Frank said. *Now, please.*

Rowena Weller was twenty-two. Since she was sixteen something had come and gone on her face and her neck and her arms, a red rash that rose into welts and wept and crusted and itched until she tore at it in her sleep, so that she woke with blood under her nails. Every doctor in Colorado Springs had looked at it. She had taken arsenic drops in water for a year. She had soaked in the soda springs at Manitou and the hot pool at Glenwood and been painted with tar and sulfur and zinc. A man in Denver had put her under the Röntgen rays, and it had come back worse. When it was bad she did not go out, and when she had to go out she wore a motoring veil of grey chiffon, tied under the chin, though the Wellers had no motorcar.

She had a temper. The hired girls did not stay. She had thrown a hand mirror at the one before this one, and missed, and broken the glass in the hall door, and the next day she had paid for it out of her own allowance without a word and without apologizing. She could not stand to be looked at, and she could not stand to be pitied, and most of all she could not stand other girls, the ones who went to the Saturday dances at the Broadmoor Casino in their summer muslins with their bare white arms. When the news came from Independence, and her father read it out at the breakfast table, she was the one who said it first, before any of the men: *They ought to hang every union man in the district.* Her father looked at her over the paper as if she had said something he had been thinking and had not liked to hear out loud.

She came to the Antlers in the veil and sat in the corner of the ladies' parlor with her gloves on.

Rowena, her brother said. *Why didn't you come with the others?*

Because of my face, Frank. I was ashamed.

He did not ask to see it. *Shouldn't you be doing some good in the world?*

What good can I do?

The Scientists in Manitou meet in a rented room over the drugstore. Twenty people on kitchen chairs. They need a church.

And what would I build it with?

You have Mother's diamonds.

She did. Their mother had died when Rowena was nine and left her a necklace and earrings and a brooch, diamonds in Cripple Creek gold, that their father had bought in Denver in the first good year at the mine. Rowena had never worn them. They lay in a velvet case in the bottom of her wardrobe.

What did they cost?

Papa said ten thousand dollars.

Then build with that.

Frank, who would build it for me?

He turned and looked at their two uncles, who were standing in the parlor door with their hats in their hands. Uncle George had the lumber yard in Colorado City. Uncle Will had built half the cottages in Manitou.

They will. That's their part.

And what will you do?

I'll stay here till it's done.

The uncles looked at each other, and at their brother, who said nothing, and at their niece in the corner in her veil, and Uncle George said, *Well. All right.* And in the morning he sent up a wagon of lumber.

II. The Lower Room

Manitou · summer and autumn 1904

They built it on a lot below Ruxton Avenue, where Ruxton Creek comes down out of the canyon talking to itself over the stones. Frank drew it on butcher paper at the kitchen table. Two stories. Below, a Sunday school room and a reading room, with a stove and a row of windows on the creek side. Above, the auditorium, with the two Readers' desks and seats for a hundred and twenty.

As soon as they put the boards down overhead, he told his sister, *you take your place below. Sweep it. Every day. Set out the chairs for the Wednesday meeting, and keep the water pitchers full.*

Frank, there'll be carpenters walking around on top of me.

There will.

On the first evening, after the uncles had gone, she found Frank alone on the porch and stood in front of him with her arms folded.

You think it's in my mind. Don't you. That I've imagined it.

I didn't say that.

Look at it, then. And she pulled up the veil.

He looked, for a long time, the way a doctor looks, without flinching and without pity, and she hated him for it, and then, for some reason, she did not.

It's real enough, he said. *Get some sleep. George is bringing the wagon at seven.*

The diamonds went to a jeweler on Sixteenth Street in Denver who did not ask questions. The foundation went in in July. In August the joists went across, and the subfloor, and on the first day of September Rowena Weller walked down from the Wellers' summer cottage on the hill in her veil with a broom over her shoulder and went in under the new boards and began to sweep.

There was a great deal to sweep. Sawdust and shavings and plaster grit and the bent nails that came down through the cracks, and the mud the men tracked in, and the leaves the wind blew in through the empty window frames. Above her head all day the carpenters walked and sawed and hammered, and the dust sifted down through the boards in the light from the windows, and she swept it up, and it sifted down again, and she swept it up. The Scientists came down from the room over the drugstore and began holding their Wednesday meetings in the lower room before there was glass in the windows, sitting on kitchen chairs among the sawhorses with their coats on, standing up one at a time to tell what they had been healed of, while the hammers went on overhead. Rowena set out the chairs for them and filled the pitchers from the creek and sat at the back in her veil and did not listen.

Frank did not preach at her. He came every afternoon and walked through the building with Uncle Will and talked about joists and window sash, and sometimes, on his way out, he stopped where she was sweeping and watched her for a minute. Once he said, *You're getting better at that.* She said a broom was not hard. He said it was harder than it looked to sweep the same floor every day and not be angry at the men who kept dirtying it, and went out, and she stood there in the dust with her face hot under the veil, because she had been angry at them all morning, every one of them, every bent nail, every boot.

It did not stop all at once. But a day came in October when she noticed that she had swept the whole floor and had not once looked up at the boards and wished the men above them dead, and the next day the same, and after that she stopped noticing.

Her stepmother noticed it first, at the end of that month. Rowena had come in with the broom and pulled off the veil to wash, and her stepmother, at the stove, looked at her and set the spoon down.

Rowena. Your neck.

The welts had gone flat and pale. Under the jaw, where it was always worst, the skin was pink and whole, like the skin under a scab that comes off clean. Rowena went to the glass in the hall and stood there a long time. She did not say anything. She put the veil back on, out of habit, and went down the hill again in the morning with the broom.

By November there was nothing on her arms. By Thanksgiving there was nothing on her face but a faint roughness along one cheekbone that you could only see in a side light, and she had stopped wearing the veil to the lower room, and the carpenters, who had been calling her the Widow for three months on account of it, were ashamed of themselves and called her Miss Weller.

The building came to eleven thousand four hundred dollars. The diamonds had brought nine thousand six hundred. It is the custom of the Christian Scientists not to dedicate a church while anything is owed on it, not a dollar, and so in December the little congregation in Manitou took up what it could, and Uncle George forgave the lumber, and Uncle

Will forgave his wages, and on the last Sunday of the year Frank Weller stood in the new auditorium and announced that the church was paid for.

III. The Teacher

Wood Avenue · January 1905

They dedicated it on the second Sunday in January, in a snow that came down soft and steady out of the canyon all morning, and afterward Rowena gave a dinner for the teacher and the members at her father's house in the North End.

The teacher was Mrs. Harriet Oakes, of Denver. She was the one who had taught Frank, and half the practitioners in Colorado; she held a class every autumn in a parlor on Capitol Hill, and people came to it from as far as Cheyenne and Santa Fe. She was a widow of fifty from western Kansas, broad and plain, in a black wool dress that had been good once. She had been a country schoolteacher for twenty years before she was a Scientist. She did not talk much. When she did, people noticed that she did not raise her voice even in a full room, and that the room got quiet to hear her.

Rowena did not sit down to the dinner. She had planned it for a month, and cooked half of it herself with the hired girl: a clear soup, and a roast of beef, and creamed oysters brought up in a tub of ice from Denver, and Saratoga potatoes, and hot rolls, and a jellied salad, and three kinds of pie and a coconut cake. She saw it onto the table and went back into the kitchen and stayed there.

When the cake had gone around, Mrs. Oakes put down her fork.

Whose dinner is this?

My sister's, said Frank.

Where is she?

In the kitchen.

Ask her to come in.

Rowena did not want to. Frank went and got her anyway, and she came and stood at the end of the table in her apron with her hands folded, and then, because Mrs. Oakes pointed to the chair beside her, she sat.

Miss Weller. Why didn't you come to any of my lectures in the fall? Your brother asked you.

I had something on my skin. I was ashamed to.

Do you know why it came?

No, Mrs. Oakes. Nobody ever knew. Eleven doctors.

It came from anger, Mrs. Oakes said.

The table went quiet. Rowena's father put his napkin down. Rowena looked at the woman beside her with her mouth a little open.

Anger at whom? What did I ever do?

Well, said Mrs. Oakes, *listen.* And she told a story the way she must have told stories to the children in the sod schoolhouse in Kansas, plainly, in order, with her hands still in her lap.

There was once a queen, she said, who had everything a queen could want. And there was a girl at the court who danced for the king, and the girl danced so well that when she danced, nobody looked at the queen. The queen could not bear it. So she sent away to some country where a certain bean grows in a pod covered with fine hairs, the kind that will set the skin on fire, and she had the pods ground into a powder. And she put the powder in the dancing girl's bed, and in her cloak, and in her blanket of goat's hair. And one day, laughing, as if it were a game, she threw a handful of it over the girl herself. The girl broke out in welts from head to foot. She tore at herself. She lay down in her bed to get away from it and the bed was full of it too. She never danced at that court again.

Mrs. Oakes was quiet a moment.

That was you, she said. *I think you know it.*

IV. Cowhage

The same evening

ROWENA DID KNOW IT. SHE HAD NOT THOUGHT ABOUT IT IN seven years, which is not the same as having forgotten.

The Christmas she was fifteen, Miss Antoinette Fry's Academy of the Dance had put on a pageant at the Opera House, with a tableau of the seasons, and Rowena was to be Winter, in white tarlatan with silver

spangles, and she had practiced the solo for two months. Then in the last week Miss Fry gave it to Lottie Kehoe. Lottie was a year younger. Her father worked the night shift at the Strong mine and her mother took in sewing, and she had come to the Academy free because Miss Fry said she had never seen feet like that on a child. She danced the way water runs. When Lottie danced, nobody looked at anybody else.

There was a boy at the high school whose people had wintered in Florida, and he had come back with a paper of what they called cow-itch down there, and sold pinches of it to the other boys for a dime to put down girls' collars. It was cowhage, the hairs off the pod of a bean that grows in the South, fine as pollen and gold-colored, though Rowena did not know the name then. She paid him a quarter for the whole paper. She shook it into the folds of Lottie's costume where it hung in the dressing room at the Opera House, and into the lining of her cloak, and on the night of the pageant, in the wings, laughing, as if it were a game the girls were all playing, she threw a pinch of it down the back of Lottie's neck.

Lottie came out as Winter in white tarlatan with silver spangles, and took four steps, and began to scratch, and then to tear at herself, and then to cry, in front of six hundred people, and ran off the stage. Her face and neck and arms came up in welts. Her mother took her home and put her to bed and the bed was full of it, because Rowena had shaken the last of the envelope into the cloak, and the cloak had been laid over her. The next spring the Kehoes moved up to Victor. Lottie never came back to the Academy. Rowena danced Winter in her place, and was very bad in it, and her skin broke out for the first time the following summer.

She sat at the end of her father's table with her hands in her lap and told it, all of it, in front of the Scientists from Manitou and her uncles and her stepmother and the hired girl standing in the kitchen door.

Then Mrs. Oakes did what a Christian Science teacher does. She did not give a lecture. She asked Frank for his Bible and his copy of *Science and Health*, which he kept in his coat, and read from the one and then the other, the way they are read in the churches on Sunday, without comment, and closed them.

> *Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice.*
>
> *— Ephesians 4:31*

> *There is no life, truth, intelligence, nor substance in matter. All is infinite Mind and its infinite manifestation, for God is All-in-all. Spirit is immortal Truth; matter is mortal error. Spirit is the real and eternal; matter is the unreal and temporal. Spirit is God, and man is His image and likeness. Therefore man is not material; he is spiritual.*
>
> *— Mary Baker Eddy, Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures, p. 468*

What happened then was told afterward at the Wednesday meetings in Manitou by eleven different people, and their accounts agreed. The snow had stopped. The sun had come out low under the clouds over the Peak, the way it does on winter afternoons in the Springs, and came in level through the west windows of the dining room. And Rowena Weller, sitting at the end of the table with her hands in her lap, turned the color of the light. Her face and her neck and her bare forearms went gold. Not flushed. Gold, they said, like gold leaf on a picture frame, like the color of the ore they bring up out of the Independence, and it stayed after the sun went behind the mountain, and the hired girl dropped a cake plate.

Frank said only that his sister looked well.

• • •

In February Rowena took the train up to Victor. It took her two days to find the Kehoes, who were living in three rooms in Goldfield; Mr. Kehoe had been put on a train to Kansas in June with the other union men and had not been allowed back. Lottie was twenty-one and sewed with her mother. She did not recognize the young woman at the door. When she did, she stood in the doorway a long time. What they said to each other there, neither of them ever told anybody, but Rowena went up to Goldfield again in March, and again in April, and the Kehoes did not go hungry that year.

V. The Four Corners

The North End · 1905

Now the Weller house stood on a corner lot on Wood Avenue, and on the other three corners of that crossing stood three other houses, and in each of the four houses, counting the Wellers' own, where the stepmother's nephew was boarding, there lived an unmarried young man. Every one of them had known Rowena Weller all her life. Not one of them had looked at her twice since she was sixteen. That spring every one of them looked at her, and went on looking, and by May the four of them were not speaking.

She grew up on my side of the street, said the first.

She grew up across from me, said the second, *I could see her window.*

She grew up in my aunt's house, said the third.

She's our corner's, said the fourth, who had no argument and knew it.

It got as far as a fistfight on the Antlers lawn, and then the four of them agreed, since no one of them would give way to another, to put it before somebody they would all abide by. They chose Tom Rainey, who was thirty-four and had come down from the Cripple Creek district in 1899 with more money than any of them could imagine, from a mine he had found himself with a pick, and who had a stone house on Cascade Avenue and was known to be fair. They went to see him on a Sunday evening in his library and laid it before him.

Tom Rainey asked each of them how it stood with him.

My heart has been going like the bass drum in the band in Acacia Park on the Fourth of July, said the first, *and it won't stop.*

My thoughts go like Ruxton Creek after a cloudburst, said the second. *All over the road.*

Since I first saw her this spring, said the third, *my eyes have stuck out like a crawdad's.*

My mind won't hold still, said the fourth, *any more than the flag on top of the Peak.*

Tom Rainey sat quiet a while in his leather chair.

Boys, he said, *you're all on fire, every one of you, and it'll pass. Now I'll tell you how it is with me. I saw her at the dedication in January. If I can have her, I'll live. If I can't, I'll die.*

The four young men looked at one another. Then the first one said, *Well, Mr. Rainey, there's no call for you to die,* and they got up and shook his hand, one after another, and went out, and on the sidewalk on Cascade Avenue under the elms they found they were speaking to each other again.

Rowena heard about it a week later and laughed until she had to sit down on the stairs. She married Tom Rainey in the new church in Manitou in October, and the four of them were ushers.

She was his darling and his delight. Whatever she said, he could not refuse her. If she said, *Tom, let's go up the Peak on the cog road tonight and watch the sun come up,* they went. If she said, *Tom, the Kehoes need a house,* the Kehoes had a house. And if she said, as she did every Saturday morning for the rest of her life, *Tom, I'm going down to sweep the Sunday school,* then the richest man in El Paso County went with her, in his good coat, and stood in the lower room of the little church on Ruxton Creek with the light coming in off the water, and held the dustpan.

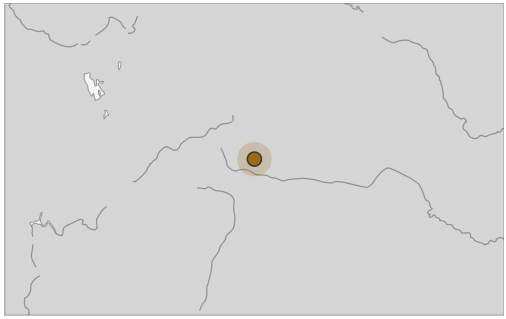
Background

The verse

> *Let a man leave anger, let him forsake pride, let him overcome all bondage! No sufferings befall the man who is not attached to name and form, and who calls nothing his own.*
>
> Dhammapada 221, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Anuruddha comes home to Kapilavatthu, and everyone in the family goes out to greet him except his sister Rohinī, who is ashamed of a skin eruption. He sends for her and tells her to sell her jewels and build a two-storied assembly hall; while the kinsfolk build it, she sweeps the lower floor and sets out seats and water, and as she sweeps her skin clears. When she gives a meal for the Buddha in the finished hall, he summons her and tells her the eruption came from anger: in a past life, as a jealous queen, she put the powder of a stinging bean in a dancing girl's

bed and clothes and threw it on her body "as if in fun." As she hears the verse her body turns the color of gold. Reborn among the gods at the meeting point of four domains, she is quarreled over by four young gods, who put the case to Sakka, their king; he wants her for himself, and they give way. Read the full commentary story. The bean is Mucuna pruriens, the velvet bean or cowhage, whose pod hairs are still used in itching powder.



Colorado Springs and Manitou, Colorado

Colorado Springs and Manitou, 1904

Colorado Springs was laid out in 1871 at the foot of Pikes Peak, and so many English settlers came that it was called "Little London"; after the gold strikes at Cripple Creek in the 1890s it filled up with mining money, and by 1895 it had four mining exchanges and 275 mining brokers. Manitou Springs, just up the canyon, was founded in 1872 as a health resort around its mineral springs. In 1903 and 1904 the district was torn by the Colorado Labor Wars. On June 6, 1904, a dynamite blast under the platform of the Independence depot killed thirteen non-union miners; in the days after, the mine owners' association and the militia rounded up union men into bullpens and deported more than two hundred of them by train across the state line.

Christian Science was founded in 1879 by Mary Baker Eddy, whose *Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures* (1875) teaches that sickness is rooted in mental error; it names "hatred, envy, dishonesty, fear, and so forth" among the things that "make a man sick." Each church has two Readers, who read paired passages from the Bible and *Science and Health* on Sundays, and members give testimonies of healing at Wednesday evening meetings. When the extension of The Mother Church in Boston was dedicated in June 1906, a Boston paper noted that no Christian Science church had ever been dedicated "with any part of the expense of its construction remaining unprovided for." The Manitou church, the Wellers, Mrs. Oakes and Tom Rainey are fictional.

After the story of the noble maiden Rohinī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 221). The original. Scripture from the King James Version and Mary Baker Eddy's *Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures*. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.2

Four Saplings

> *I govern it well in its course by the bridle of knowledge; it does not go astray with me, it keeps to the right path.*
> *— Uttarādhyayana Sūtra 23:56*

Evu me sambhalyu chhe, on the Vora family Realm.

I. Peaceful

Schaumburg, Illinois · spring 2020

Kanchanben Vora was seventy-four the spring the derasar in Bartlett locked its doors, and in eleven years she had hardly missed a morning there. Now she did her samayik in the bedroom over the garage, forty-eight minutes by the sand timer, facing a calendar picture of Shatrunjay. After that there was the whole day.

Her granddaughter Riya put the game on the iPad in the second week of March. It was so Ba could see the cousins. The family was in eleven houses in three countries and nobody could go to anybody. Riya made the world on Ba's own account, which made Ba its owner, and that suited everyone, since Ba was the one person all the branches of the family would obey. They named the world Vadi, the orchard.

Ba learned to walk in it in two days and to look up in four. She wanted every setting read out to her. At Difficulty she stopped Riya.

What is Peaceful?

No monsters. Nobody gets hungry. It's kind of the baby setting, Ba.

That one. Nothing is hunted in my house.

She had other rules. Nobody killed the cows or the chickens. Nobody dug up a carrot or a potato where she could see it. The cousins called this Jain mode, laughed about it for a week, and came anyway, forty of them

by May, because it was where Ba was. She stood at the gate in the plain blue shirt the game gives everyone and asked each one who arrived whether they had eaten.

She built at the place where people first appear, a low hall of birch with a garden behind it and a wall around both, and for three months the rule was that everybody built inside the wall where she could see them. By June the compound was packed like a pol in old Ahmedabad, roof against roof. So Ba gave permission. Whoever wanted could go out through the gate, take ground that was empty, and build there.

One house stood outside already. Hetal was married to Ba's grandson Ankit and lived on the ninth floor of a building in Brampton, Ontario, with their son Aarav, who was five. Ankit was a respiratory therapist. Since March he had slept in a motel near the hospital so as not to carry anything home, and he waved to the boy from the parking lot on Sundays. The playground behind the building was wrapped in yellow tape.

In her first week in the world Hetal had walked out past where the wall would be and set four dark oak saplings in a square, which is the only way that tree will grow. It came up as thick as a room. She built a floor in its crown, with a bed for her, a bed for Aarav and a chest for his things, and Ba let it be. Every afternoon that spring, while the swings stood taped, Aarav was out in his tree.

II. Outside the Wall

The Realm · August, the third night of Paryushan

Kunal was fifteen, the grandson of Ba's sister, in Edison, New Jersey. He had drawn his house on graph paper before he placed a block of it: a long hall with a dark roof, the first big thing anyone had planned beyond the gate. He had counted the logs. The dark oak forest was most of an hour's walk to the north. One dark oak stood a minute from the wall.

He came to it with an iron axe a little after nine, Eastern time, and started at the root.

Hetal was upstairs in it with Aarav. In the kitchen in Brampton the boy sat beside her at the table with the old tablet, up too late, as he had been all summer. She typed fast.

Kunal please don't. This is our house. I can't go wandering around with him looking for somewhere else to live.

There's no other tree like this one, bhabhi, he typed back. *I'll be quick.*

He did not stop. He had his headphones on and his thumb down on the button, the way you hold it for a trunk that size, and the axe rose and fell without his deciding each stroke.

If he sees the child he will stop, Hetal thought. She said it aloud in the kitchen. *Go stand on the low branch, beta, where Kunal bhaiya can see you.* Aarav walked out along the branch and stood over his cousin's head with the poppy he always carried.

The axe was already coming up. It caught the boy, knocked him off the branch, and he fell the height of the tree.

All that Aarav had ever seen of himself in that world was his own right arm, held out in front of him with the flower in it. The screen went red. The arm was gone. Then there were gray words he could not read yet. He was five, and he screamed in the kitchen as if it had been done to him, and when Hetal reached for him he got down under the table and would not be touched.

A line came up in the corner of everyone's screen saying that Aarav had fallen from a high place. Kunal read it and went on with the tree. It was a game, and people fell.

III. Both Hands

Brampton, Ontario · the same night

Hetal had been given operator rights in April, to fix things for Ba. There was one line she could type that would drop Kunal dead where he stood and spill everything he carried on the grass. She typed it with her right thumb and did not send it.

Her phone was in her left hand, open to Vora Parivar, sixty-three members. She had four lines written there about Kunal, who had been

told, who had seen a child and kept swinging. She had one more about his mother, who had said a thing at Hetal's wedding that Hetal had carried for six years. Both thumbs were up.

Under the table Aarav had stopped screaming and was only breathing loudly.

Three thoughts came to her, one behind the other, and she remembered afterward that they came in order. He was a decent boy. He sat his pratikraman on a screen beside his grandmother every evening that week, and what she did to him tonight she would carry herself for a long time. Then she thought of the other mothers in that group. If she set the price of a tree at a boy's name in front of sixty-three people, every auntie would know the price by morning, and it would be paid again on other children. And the place had an owner. This was Ba's house.

She put the game down first, and then the phone, on its face. She got under the table and brought her son out against her shoulder, and with her free hand she called Illinois.

IV. The Bridle

Schaumburg · later that night

Ba had finished the evening pratikraman and was sitting with her mala. She propped the iPad against the steel dabba on the dresser. For the first minute all she could see was a ceiling in Brampton, and all she could hear was crying. She waited.

Hetal told her all of it: the four saplings in March, the axe, the branch, the arm. She said what she had written with each hand, read both aloud, and told the three things she had thought. She had sent nothing.

Shabash, beta, Ba said. *Shabash.*

Then she told her about Kesi and Gautama, two monks of two lineages who met in a park outside Shravasti, where the elder asked the younger one riddle after another. She told it in Gujarati, as her own mother had told it during the rains. In the old English translation that Riya later found for the cousins, the part she told runs like this.

'The unruly, dreadful, bad horse, on which you sit, runs about, Gautama! how comes it to pass that it does not run off with you?'

'I govern it well in its course by the bridle of knowledge; it does not go astray with me, it keeps to the right path.'

— Uttarādhyayana Sūtra 23:55–56

It was up and running tonight, Ba said. *Most of us only sit behind and hold the reins while it takes us where it likes. You drove.*

Hetal heard that, and something in her that had been braced since half past nine gave way and was quiet. The family tells that part as she told it. She went on crying all the same.

What is it now?

Ba, the tree is gone. He took it down to the dirt. Where are we supposed to live?

Bas. Enough, said Ba. *There is the birch by my garden wall, the one that stands by itself. Dhruv had his room in it. Yesterday he started back at the warehouse and he tells me he is finished with games. Go in there.*

V. The Tree by Itself

The Realm · to Samvatsari

They moved that night, the chest and both beds. For two days Aarav would not hold the tablet. On the third he sat in his mother's lap and let her walk him to the window of the new house, which looked into Ba's garden, where Ba in her blue shirt was putting in wheat.

The morning after the call, when her samayik was done, Ba wrote a rule on a sign at the gate, with one finger, and it took her some time. Nobody cuts a tree that someone lives in. Nobody cuts any tree or growing thing without need, and whoever cuts, plants.

The older cousins brought it to her on the family call. *Ba, they're blocks.*

Then who was crying? she said.

Riya had started looking things up by then, and in another volume of the same old translation she found a man and a plant set side by side, a

line the cousins took to quoting at one another over every sapling: *as this falls sick when cut, so that falls sick when cut.*

The birch became a game of its own. Everybody tried it. Kunal's older brother came with a diamond axe and operator rights he had talked Riya into, and the cracks spread across the white bark as they should, and then closed. The log stayed. Two uncles tried, one of whom writes software for a bank. Riya went through every setting the Realm had, twice, and found nothing that could do that. When they asked Ba she said she had given the tree to Hetal and the child, and that was all she had done.

Samvatsari fell on the Saturday. When the long pratikraman ended, the phones in eleven houses filled with the same two words, micchami dukkadam, sixty-three times over, and Kunal's came among them like everyone's.

Afterward he went into the world alone. He walked out through the gate to the bare square of dirt a minute from the wall and set four saplings in it, close together, two and two. He had bone meal in his pack that would have brought the tree up at once, and he left it there. He stood and waited the slow way.

From the top of the wall Aarav watched him, with a poppy held out in front of him in his right hand, where he could see it.

Background

The verse

> *He who holds back rising anger like a rolling chariot, him I call a real driver; other people are but holding the reins.*
>
> Dhammapada 222, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha has just allowed his monks to build lodgings outside the monastery walls. A monk of Āḷavī picks a tree and starts to cut it down. The spirit who lives in the tree comes out with her infant on her hip and begs him to spare her home; he says he will not find another tree like it. Hoping the sight of the child will stop him, she sets the child on a branch, but the axe is already swinging and it cuts off the child's arm. She raises both hands to strike the monk dead, then thinks better of it for three reasons and goes weeping to the Buddha, who praises her,

speaks the verse, gives her a tree near his own chamber that no one afterward can shake, and makes it a rule that monks must not injure trees and plants. Read the full commentary story.

Schaumburg, Illinois

A Jain family, 2020

Jains have lived in the United States and Canada in numbers since the 1960s; see Jainism in the United States. The temple of the Jain Society of Metropolitan Chicago stands in Bartlett, Illinois. Non-violence toward every living thing, plants included, is the center of Jain practice, and many observant Jains avoid root vegetables because pulling them kills the whole plant. In the eight days of Paryushana, which in 2020 ran from August 15 to August 22 for most Śvetāmbara Jains, families fast and sit the evening rite of repentance. On the last day, Samvatsari, each person asks forgiveness of everyone they know with the words *micchami dukkadam*. With temples closed by the pandemic that year, the rites were held by video call. The dialogue of Kesi and Gautama is the twenty-third lecture of the Uttarādhyayana Sūtra, quoted here from Hermann Jacobi's translation in the *Sacred Books of the East* (1895). The line about a plant falling sick is from his translation of the Ācārāṅga Sūtra (1884).

Minecraft reported 126 million monthly players in May 2020, and in that lockdown spring many families used it as a place to meet. On a private Realm the owner sets the difficulty, and Peaceful removes monsters and hunger. A dark oak grows only from four saplings planted in a square. Playgrounds across Ontario were closed by emergency order that spring.

After the story of a certain bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 222). The original. Scripture from the Uttarādhyayana and Ācārāṅga Sūtras, tr. Hermann Jacobi (1895, 1884). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

17.3

The Red Umbrella

to recompense injury with kindness.
— Tao Teh King 63:1

Ngo teng yan gam gong, under the temple eaves on the Feather River.

I. The Furrow

Oroville, California · New Year, 1875

Lau Ping worked for the merchant Fong Yat-sun, who kept the biggest store in Chinatown and a fan-tan house behind it, and who owned four mules, a wagon, two ditches and a strip of river bottom below the town where his men grew bok choy and winter melon to sell to the miners up the canyons. Lau Ping hauled for him, dug for him, plowed for him, and was paid a dollar a day when there was work and nothing when there was not. His wife cooked in the Fong kitchen. His daughter, Ah Lin, who was sixteen and had been born in a tent on the river at Bidwell Bar, swept the Fong floors and carried the Fong wash down to the water. All three of them slept in a lean-to against the back wall of the store, the last place in Chinatown before the willows.

On the last night of the old year the whole street went up in firecrackers. Red paper hung on every door, and the smell of powder and roast pork lay over the town so thick the white people from up the hill came down to the edge of it to look. The merchants shut their counters for a week. The miners came in from Cherokee Flat and Morris Ravine in clean blue cotton and gambled away the winter.

In the morning old Fong stood in the door of the store with a red envelope in his hand and said: *Ping, the men want New Year. Will you take New Year, or will you work?*

New Year is for people with money, Lau Ping said. *I don't have rice in the house for tomorrow's jook. Let me take the mules and go plow.*

Plow, then.

Lau Ping put his head into the lean-to and said to his wife: *Everybody is eating today. I'm plowing. When you bring my rice, cook me twice what you usually cook.* And he took the mules and went down to the bottom.

There was a man at the temple called Brother Hui. He was younger than the Old Teacher who kept the place, perhaps forty, with a long jaw and shoulders like a boatman's, and he had been sitting in the back room of the temple since the twenty-fourth day of the last month, the day the Kitchen God goes up to heaven. He had not eaten or moved or spoken in seven days, and the men who came in to burn incense walked around him on their toes. On New Year's morning, while the street was still smoking from the night, he got up, took his bowl and a square of cotton he used to strain water, and walked out past the last house into the willows. He stood on the bank of an irrigation ditch above the field where Lau Ping was plowing and looked for a long time at a bush of wild rose.

Lau Ping saw him there. He left the mules standing in the furrow, went and bowed to the ground on the wet earth, and stood up and said: *You'll want something to clean your teeth.* He cut a willow twig, chewed the end of it soft for him, and handed it up. Brother Hui gave him the bowl and the square of cotton. *He wants water,* Lau Ping thought, and went down to the ditch and strained the water through the cloth until it ran clear of the river silt, and brought it back.

Brother Hui drank. Then he stood a while longer on the bank. The lean-to was the last house of all, back against the wall where no one could see a man standing at its door, and so he waited where he was until he saw Lau Ping's wife come out of the willows on the path with the rice pot wrapped in a cloth, and then he started toward the town as if he had only been passing.

Lau Ping's wife saw him on the path and stopped. She thought: *Once when I had something to give I never saw one of them. Once when I saw one of them I had nothing to give. Today I see one, and I have rice in my hands.* She set the pot down on the path and bowed to the earth.

Don't think about whether it's coarse or fine, she said. *Just let it be a blessing.*

He held out the bowl. She held the pot on her hip and filled it with her hand. When she had given him half, he put his palm over the bowl and said, *Enough.*

One meal can't be cut in two, she said. *Don't bless me in this life. Bless me in the next one. Let me give it all.* She tipped the pot and the rest went in, and she said: *Let me see what you have seen.*

So be it, said Brother Hui. He said the words of thanks standing there on the path. Then he went and sat by the ditch where the water ran clean and ate, and she went back to the lean-to and found more rice somewhere, nobody ever said where, and cooked it.

Lau Ping plowed half an acre and could not plow any more. He unhitched the mules and sat down under a valley oak by the path to watch for her. When she came out of the willows with the pot she saw him sitting with his head down and the mule whip across his knees, and she thought, *If he says I'm late and hits me with the handle, what I did this morning goes for nothing.* So she spoke first.

Husband, be patient with me today, only today. Don't spoil what I did. I was on my way here at sunrise, and I met the man from the temple who sits, and I gave him your rice. I went back and cooked again. Be glad.

What did you say?

She told him again.

You did right, said Lau Ping. *I gave him a willow twig and clean water this morning myself.* He ate, and then, because he had not eaten since the day before and the sun was warm on that side of the oak, he put his head in her lap and slept.

When he woke the furrows were gold. All the ground he had broken that morning lay turned up and shining the color of the poppies that come out on Table Mountain in March, a whole hillside of them at once.

Look at that field, he said. *Is that gold? Or am I seeing things because I'm hungry?*

I see it too.

He walked out into the furrow and picked up a clod and knocked it against the plowshare, and it rang.

II. The Umbrella

The company hall · the same week

He sat down in the field with the clod in his hand and thought about what happens on this river to a Chinese man with gold.

He had paid the Foreign Miners' Tax at Bidwell Bar for nine years, three dollars a month and then four, every month, to a collector with a pistol and a receipt book, and he had seen what the collectors did when a man said he had paid already. He had seen claims jumped, and cabins burned, and a man from his own village tied by his queue to a hitching rail. He had seen a judge in Marysville send a Chinese witness home because a Chinese witness could not speak against a white man. You could not hide a field. You could not spend it either.

So he filled his wife's rice basket with gold dirt, put a cloth over it, and carried it up through the New Year crowds to the company hall beside the temple, where Old Ma, the president of the company, sat in a carved chair with a teacup and settled the quarrels of four thousand men.

What is it? said Old Ma.

Uncle, all the ground I plowed this morning has turned to gold. You should send carts and bring it here, before somebody else does.

Who are you?

Lau Ping. I work for Fong Yat-sun.

And what did you do this morning?

Lau Ping told him: the willow twig, the water strained through the cloth, the rice his wife had given on the path. Old Ma set down his cup.

Then that's what this is, he said. *You're seeing it come back to you on the same day. Well, friend, what should I do?*

Send carts.

Old Ma sent every cart in Chinatown and every man who could push a wheelbarrow, and they went down to the bottom shouting to each other over the firecrackers, and as they shoveled they said what anybody would

have said: *This belongs to the company.* And every shovelful turned back to river mud the moment it was lifted. They tipped the barrows out and filled them again, and it was mud again. They came back up the hill with mud to the elbows and stood in the hall and told Old Ma.

What were you saying while you dug?

That it was the company's.

Old Ma laughed until he had to wipe his eyes. *Who am I? Go back down. Say it belongs to Lau Ping.*

They went back down and said it, and the mud in their shovels was gold again. They brought it up the hill all afternoon and all the next day and heaped it in the yard between the hall and the temple, and the heap rose past the eaves and past the incense urn, until the boys climbing it on a dare could look down on the temple roof.

Old Ma had the merchants and the headmen of every village association in town brought into the yard. *Is there anybody on this river with as much as this?*

Nobody, Uncle.

What should he have?

Somebody said the umbrella. In the old country, when a district magistrate had done well by the people, they gave him the ten-thousand-people umbrella when he left, red silk with the names of the givers stitched all over it in gold thread. There was one in the company hall that had come over on a ship years ago for some reason nobody remembered, folded in paper in a camphor chest. Old Ma had it brought out and opened over Lau Ping's head in the yard, and the silk was faded to the color of a ripe persimmon, and the gold names on it had gone brown, and nobody could read half of them.

Let him be called Lau Daai Fu, said Old Ma. *Lau the Greatly Rich.* And everything in the yard was his.

Uncle, said Lau Ping, under the umbrella, *all my life I've slept in other people's houses. Give me somewhere to build one.*

Old Ma pointed across the street to the lot where the old Sam Kee store had stood until it burned, which was nothing now but a chimney and a thicket of blackberry. *Clear that and build there.*

He built a house of brick from the yard at Palermo, two stories, with an iron door like the stores had against fire. When it was done he held two feasts on the same day, one for the house and one for the umbrella, and for seven days after that he fed the Old Teacher and every man who lived at the temple at his own table. On the last day, after the meal, the Old Teacher spoke a little, the way he did, about what is given and what is kept.

> *The sage does not accumulate (for himself). The more that he expends for others, the more does he possess of his own; the more that he gives to others, the more does he have himself.*
>
> *— Tao Teh King 81:2*

Lau Ping and his wife and Ah Lin sat on the floor at the edge of the room and listened, and when he had finished, all three of them knew something they had not known that morning and would never not know again. Nobody in the town could have said what it was. You could only see it afterward, in how they put down a cup.

III. The Match

Chinatown · spring 1876

Old Fong came across the street in the spring with his hat in his hand.

That was the year after the Congress in Washington passed the law about Chinese women. In Hong Kong now every woman who wanted to sail had to stand in front of the American consul with her photograph and answer him about her father, her husband, her feet, her character, and the way she walked across the room, and then answer the harbor master, and then answer again on the dock in San Francisco, where they held the photograph up beside her face. Most of them did not come. Wives who had been sent for in letters stayed in the villages. Fong's son Wing had been promised a girl from Toishan since he was eleven years old, and she was not coming. In all of Butte County there were perhaps a

dozen Chinese girls who were not owned by somebody, and one of them was Ah Lin.

I won't give her, said Lau Ping.

Ping. Don't be this way. All those years you lived against my wall. Now you're rich and you have the umbrella. Give her to my son.

Lau Ping said nothing more to Fong, but he said to his wife that night: *That house laughs at the temple. There's a fan-tan table in the back and the boy has never burned a stick of incense in his life. The girl can't live without the Old Teacher. I won't do it.*

Then the merchants came, one after another, and the headmen, and the company bookkeeper, and at last Old Ma himself, and every one of them said the same thing. *Don't break with the Fongs over this. You'll need friends on this street when the gold is gone. And who else is there for her? Who else is there for him?* And at last he gave in to them. On the fifteenth day of the fourth month, under the full moon that opens the summer retreat, when the Old Teacher and the men at the temple begin their summer of sitting, Ah Lin went across the street to the Fong house in the teak sedan chair from the temple, behind a band of gongs and a string of firecrackers that the whole town heard.

IV. The Bargain

The Fong house · summer 1876

FROM THE DAY SHE WENT ACROSS THE STREET SHE DID NOT SEE the inside of the temple. She was not allowed to burn incense or carry rice to the Old Teacher's door or sit at the edge of the room where he talked. Fong's wife kept the household money and gave her none. Wing kept his evenings at the fan-tan table and his afternoons in bed. When she asked to go across the street on the first and fifteenth, the days everybody went, her mother-in-law said the girl had married into a house of business, not a house of beggars, and that the shaved heads could feed themselves.

Two months and a half went by like that. One evening in the seventh month she asked the old woman who did her hair: *How much of the summer is left?*

Half a month, Young Mistress. Then it's the Ghost Festival.

So she sent a message across the street by the boy who carried the water. *Why did you put me in this prison? It would have been better to brand me on the face and sell me on the upper street like a girl off the ship than to give me to a house like this one. Since the day I came here I have not once seen the Teacher or given one bowl of rice to anyone.*

Lau Ping read it standing in the door of his brick house and said, *My poor girl. My poor girl.* Then he went upstairs to the iron box.

There was a woman in Marysville they called Chin Gam, Thousand Gold, because that was what she cost. She had come over before the law, at fourteen, under a paper that sold her for four years to a house on the alley behind First Street, and at eighteen she had paid off the paper and bought the house. She sang the old operas with a voice that made grown men from the Sze Yup districts weep into their sleeves. She had her own carriage and her own driver. A visit with her was a hundred dollars for a single night, and men paid it.

Lau Ping sent fifteen hundred dollars in twenty-dollar gold pieces across the street in a lacquer box, and a letter. *Send for Chin Gam. Give her this. Put her in your husband's rooms for a fortnight. Then do as you like.*

Ah Lin sent the water boy to Marysville on the stage. Chin Gam came up the next day in her carriage, in grey silk, with two maids, and sat in the Fong parlor drinking tea as if it were her own.

Elder Sister, said Ah Lin, and set the lacquer box on the table between them. *Take this, and look after my husband for fifteen days.*

Chin Gam opened the box and looked into it for a moment and closed it. *Very well.*

Ah Lin took her upstairs to Wing, who was lying in his shirt with the shutters closed.

What's this?

For fifteen days my friend will keep your rooms. For fifteen days I'm going to give rice and listen to the Teacher.

Wing looked at Chin Gam, who was the most beautiful woman between Sacramento and the mountains and knew it, and wanted her so badly his mouth went dry. *Fine,* he said. *Do what you want.*

The same afternoon Ah Lin crossed the street to the temple for the first time since spring, went in under the lanterns, knelt on the floor in front of the Old Teacher and said: *Teacher, for the next fifteen days, until the Ghost Festival, eat at my house. Don't go anywhere else.* He looked at her for a while and nodded once. She walked back across the street so lightly the water boy said afterward that her shoes did not touch the dust.

V. The Ladle

The Fong kitchen · the fourteenth day of the seventh month

For two weeks the Old Teacher and the temple men came every noon and ate in the Fong front room, and the Fong women stayed out of it, and Wing stayed upstairs. Ah Lin was in the kitchen from before light. It was a long brick room at the back of the house with two iron woks set in a clay stove the length of one wall, and a chopping table, and a door open onto the yard because the heat of the valley at the end of summer came up out of the ground and lay on the town like a lid. She cooked rice and rice and rice. She steamed buns. She sent the boy for winter melon, bean curd, dried mushrooms off the ship from San Francisco. For the last day, the eve of the festival, she had the women making sesame balls, the round ones you fry slowly in a full wok of peanut oil until they swell up hollow and gold, a hundred and more, for the Teacher's men and for the hungry dead who would be fed at the river the next night.

That afternoon Wing stood at his window upstairs looking down across the yard into the kitchen door. *Tomorrow's their festival,* he thought. *What is that fool doing?* He saw her going back and forth between the stove and the table in an old blue jacket with the sleeves tied back, her face streaked where she had wiped it with her wrist, her hair grey with ash from the firebox and her hands black with charcoal, and she was smiling. *Look at her,* he thought. *She could be lying upstairs on silk. She'd*

rather sweat in a kitchen for a gang of shaved heads, and it makes her happy. He laughed out loud and went away from the window.

Chin Gam was in the room behind him, combing out her hair. She had been mistress of those rooms for fourteen days. She had given orders to the Fong servants, and the Fong servants had obeyed her, and somewhere in those fourteen days she had stopped remembering that she was being paid. She thought she was the woman of the house.

What made him laugh? She went to the window and looked where he had looked, and saw Ah Lin in the kitchen door. *So that's it,* she thought. *There's something between them still.*

It went through her like a burn. She put down the comb, went down the back stairs and across the yard and into the kitchen, straight to the stove where the oil sat rolling in the big wok with the sesame balls turning in it, and she took the long iron ladle off its hook and dipped it full.

Ah Lin turned from the table and saw her coming across the brick floor with the ladle smoking in her hand.

She thought: *This woman has done me the greatest kindness of my life. The world is very small and heaven is very low, and her goodness is bigger than both, because of her I've had fifteen days with the Teacher. If I hold anything against her, let this burn me. If I hold nothing, let it not.* And she stood still, and as Chin Gam came toward her she wished her well, the whole of her, the grey silk and the bare feet on the brick and the face twisted up with hurt, as plainly and as entirely as she would have wished her own mother well.

Chin Gam threw the oil over her head.

It ran down Ah Lin's hair and her face and inside the collar of the blue jacket, and it was cool. It was like a dipper of water from the well at the back of the yard on the hottest afternoon of the year, poured over her head for no reason by somebody who loved her.

The next one will be hot, said Chin Gam, and turned to the wok and dipped the ladle full again.

The kitchen women saw it. They came at her from every side of the room with whatever they had in their hands. *You dog! You thing! Pour oil on our mistress?* They tore the ladle out of her hand and beat her with their fists and kicked her with their cloth shoes and pulled her down on the

brick floor by the hair, and Ah Lin, with oil still running out of her own hair into her eyes, tried to stop them and could not.

At last she got in among them. She pushed them back one by one with both hands until she was standing over Chin Gam, who lay on the floor with her arms over her face and the grey silk torn off one shoulder.

Why would you do such a thing? said Ah Lin.

Then she sent the women for hot water. She knelt and bathed Chin Gam's face and arms where they had scratched her and her ribs where they had kicked her, and when that was done she sent across the street to her mother's house for the little jar of camellia oil, the good one, pressed so many times it was clear as water, that her mother had saved for the day she died. Ah Lin rubbed it into the bruises with her fingers, slowly, the way you would for a child who had fallen.

Chin Gam lay on the kitchen floor and felt it. Somewhere in the middle of it she understood, all at once, that this was not her house. She had been bought for fifteen days with a lacquer box, and the fifteen days were nearly over, and the woman with her fingers on her ribs was the one who had bought her. And she thought: *I threw boiling oil at her because a man laughed. And she pulled them off me and did this.* She thought that if she did not ask to be forgiven her head would split open on the brick.

She got up onto her knees and put her forehead down on Ah Lin's feet. *Forgive me, Young Mistress.*

I'm somebody's daughter, and my father is living, Ah Lin said. *If my father forgives you, I'll forgive you.*

Then I'll go and ask Lau Daai Fu.

Lau Daai Fu is my father in this life. If my father outside of this life forgives you, I'll forgive you.

Who is that?

The Teacher.

Chin Gam sat back on her heels on the kitchen floor with her hair down. *I don't believe in that old man.*

I'll make you believe in him, said Ah Lin. *Tomorrow he's coming here with all of them. Bring whatever you can bring and come and ask him.*

VI. The Lanterns

The fifteenth day of the seventh month · the Ghost Festival

Chin Gam went down to Marysville that night on the late stage and did not sleep. In the morning she came back up the valley road in her carriage with two wagons behind it, and in the wagons were the women of her house and of every house on the alley behind First Street, the singing girls and the ones who were not singing girls, the ones who had paid off their paper and the ones who were still four years from it, forty-one of them, in the best clothes they had. They had roast duck and soy-sauce chicken and steamed white cakes and a whole roast pig on a board, and nobody in Oroville had ever seen anything like it come up the road, and half the town walked alongside the wagons to the Fong door to see what it was.

When they got to the front room the Old Teacher and his men were already sitting down with their bowls, and the women stood along the wall with the dishes in their hands and did not dare to come forward and put anything in a single bowl. Ah Lin went down the wall and took the dishes from them one at a time and carried them to the table and served everything out herself.

When the meal was finished, Chin Gam and the forty-one women came and knelt on the floor in front of the Old Teacher, all at once, with a sound like a flock of birds coming down.

He was a small man with a sparse white beard and a herbalist's yellow fingers. He had lived in the back of the temple for eleven years and almost nobody knew where he had come from. He looked at Chin Gam a long time.

What have you done?

Teacher, yesterday I did such and such. She told it all, the window and the laugh and the ladle. *And she only pulled her women off me and couldn't do enough for me. I knew what she was and I asked her to forgive me, and she said if you forgive me she will.*

Is this so, Ah Lin?

Yes, Teacher. My friend poured boiling oil on my head.

And what did you think while she was pouring it?

I thought: this woman has done me the greatest kindness of my life. The world is very small and heaven is very low, and her goodness is bigger than both, because of her I've had fifteen days with the Teacher. If I hold anything against her, let this burn me. If I hold nothing, let it not.

Good, said the Old Teacher. *Good, Ah Lin. That's the way.* And then, to all of them, the way he said everything, as if he were telling somebody where the well was:

> *To those who are good (to me), I am good; and to those who are not good (to me), I am also good;—and thus (all) get to be good. To those who are sincere (with me), I am sincere; and to those who are not sincere (with me), I am also sincere;—and thus (all) get to be sincere.*
>
> *— Tao Teh King 49:2*

He was quiet for a while. Somebody's chopsticks fell. Then he said one line more.

> *(It is the way of the Tao) to act without (thinking of) acting; to conduct affairs without (feeling the) trouble of them; to taste without discerning any flavour; to consider what is small as great, and a few as many; and to recompense injury with kindness.*
>
> *— Tao Teh King 63:1*

The women on the floor did not move. The ones who were there would say later that it was like setting down a load you had carried so long you had stopped knowing it was there. Chin Gam knelt with her hands flat on the floorboards and her bruised face lifted up toward the old man, and whatever turned over in her then never turned back. Of the forty-one women, every one of them felt it, and not one of them could ever say what it was, except that they came back up the valley road to the temple on the first and fifteenth of every month for the rest of their lives, and some of those lives were long.

• • •

That night the town went down to the river for the hungry dead. There were paper lanterns shaped like lotus flowers with a candle in each, and paper houses and paper money burned on the bank for the ones who had died on this river with nobody to feed them, the men drowned at the bars and crushed in the tunnels and shot on their claims and buried in the gravel without a name. The Old Teacher's men chanted. The children ran with sparklers. White people stood on the levee in the dark to watch.

Ah Lin came down to the water with Chin Gam beside her. It had begun to rain a little, a warm thin summer rain off the mountains, and Lau Ping walked behind the two of them with the old red umbrella open, the ten-thousand-people umbrella with the gold names worn brown, and held it over both their heads.

Chin Gam lit her lantern from Ah Lin's and set it on the water. Then she put her hand up and touched Ah Lin's hair, where the oil had gone, and it was soft and black and smelled of sesame, and there was not a mark on her anywhere. The two lanterns turned once together in the eddy below the bank and went out into the current, and the Feather River took them down in the dark toward Marysville, with all the others, a long slow line of little lights on the black water as far as anybody could see.

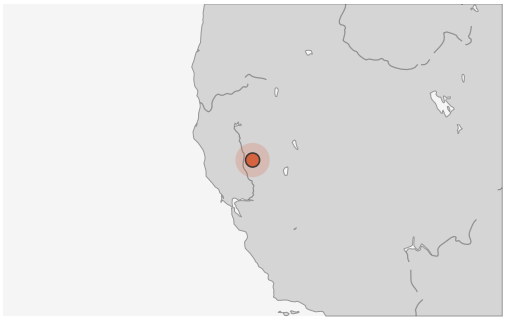
Background

The verse

> *Let a man overcome anger by love, let him overcome evil by good; let him overcome the greedy by liberality, the liar by truth!*
>
> Dhammapada 223, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Puṇṇa is a poor laborer in Rājagaha who chooses to plow on a city holiday. He gives the Elder Sāriputta a tooth-stick and strained water, and his wife gives the elder the rice she was bringing to her husband. The plowed field turns to gold. When the king's men gather it as the king's property it turns back to earth, and it turns to gold again once they call it Puṇṇa's. Made a rich man, Puṇṇa is pressed into marrying his daughter Uttarā to the son of an unbelieving family, where she can neither give alms nor hear the teaching. Her father sends money to hire the courtesan Sirimā as her husband's companion for a fortnight, so that Uttarā can feed

the Buddha and his monks until the end of the rains. When the husband laughs at Uttarā sweating in the kitchen, Sirimā throws boiling oil on her head. Uttarā holds no anger, and the oil feels cool. She pulls her servants off Sirimā and tends her wounds, and Sirimā begs forgiveness before the Buddha, who praises Uttarā with the verse above. Read the full commentary story, or about Uttarā Nandamātā.



Oroville, California

Oroville, 1875

Chinese gold-seekers, most of them from Guangdong, began reaching the Feather River in 1849, and for decades they worked claims that others had abandoned as played out. The state taxed them for it. The Foreign Miners' Tax began at twenty dollars a month in 1850 and was reset at three dollars in 1852. By 1853 it was four dollars, collected monthly, and in practice it fell mainly on the Chinese. In People v. Hall (1854) the California Supreme Court ruled that Chinese witnesses could not testify against a white man. The town first called Ophir City was renamed Oroville in 1854 and grew up as the head of navigation on the Feather River. Its brick Chinese Temple, finished in 1863 after two earlier buildings burned, served the largest Chinese community north of Sacramento. It still stands, with its altars, its processional shrines and its teak bridal sedan chair.

On March 3, 1875, President Grant signed the Page Act, which barred Asian women brought for prostitution. In practice it shut out nearly all Chinese women. Each woman had to be examined by the American consul in Hong Kong, then by the harbor master, then again on arrival in San Francisco, where officials compared her face to her photograph and judged her answers, her feet and her bearing. In 1882 only 136 of 39,579 Chinese arrivals were women. That year Congress passed the Chinese Exclusion Act, and the bachelor communities of the gold country slowly grew old and dwindled.

After the story of the lay disciple Uttarā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 223). The original. Scripture from the *Tao Teh King*, tr. James Legge (1891). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.4

As If Living

...and the person fully described, as if living.
— Instructions to Assistant Marshals, Ninth Census (1870)

I heard it told this way, down on Caney Creek.

I. The Portfolio

Brazoria, Texas · June 1870

Moses Gallion was born with a veil over his face, and his mother said that was why he could find things. When he was six he walked straight out into the canebrake below the Ransom quarter and came back leading a two-year-old girl everybody else had been calling for since noon. When he was eleven he told the overseer where the strayed mules were, and they were there. Later he found a drowned man in Caney Creek that three boats had dragged for, and after that the people on the creek stopped asking him to find things and started being a little careful around him, the way you are careful around a well.

He was twenty-six in the summer of 1870. He could read and write, which he had learned in a Bureau school in a church at Brazoria from a Massachusetts woman who kept a switch on her desk and never once used it. He had a good hand. That was why, in June, a man from the marshal's office came down the river and swore him in on the courthouse steps as an assistant marshal of the United States, and gave him a leather portfolio of blank schedules and a printed sheet of instructions, and told him he would be paid by the name, two cents for every living person and two cents for every dead one.

He read the instructions that night by a lard lamp, all of them, twice. Every person in the family was to be written, the head first, with the fam-

ily name before each given name. The column for color was always to be filled. The entries were to be read over to the party giving the information, *that all mistakes may be corrected on the spot.* He was to make the enumeration *by actual inquiry at every dwelling-house.* The duty could not be performed by deputy or proxy. There was a sentence he read four times:

> *They will approach every individual in a conciliatory manner; respect the prejudices of all; adapt their inquiries to the comprehension of foreigners and persons of limited education; and strive in every way to relieve the performance of their duties from the appearance of obtrusiveness.*
>
> *— Instructions to Assistant Marshals, Ninth Census (1870)*

He did not know what obtrusiveness was. He looked it up in the Massachusetts woman's dictionary, which she had left to the church when she went home, and understood that it meant coming into a house as if it were yours.

There were more than five thousand people in the county who had been owned in the last census. They had been written down in that one by age and sex and color, a number in a column under a white man's name. Nobody had ever asked them anything. Moses went up Caney Creek on a borrowed mule in the heat of June and asked them, at every cabin in every old quarter, in the shade of the galleries, with his portfolio on his knee: the name, the age at the last birthday, the trade, whether they could read, whether they could write, where they were born. Some of them gave him a name they had picked out in 1865 and were trying for the first time. Some of them asked him to read it back twice. An old woman at the Varner place asked him to spell hers out loud so she could hear what it looked like.

There was a second schedule, for the dead. Every person who had died in the twelve months ending the first of June, with the age and the cause. He wrote those too. That year on Caney Creek it was mostly congestion of the lungs in the winter and flux in the summer, and a man kicked by a mule, and a good many children. In March, on the Ransom place, there

had been an old woman named Hagar Bell, sixty, of a cough. He had known her all his life. She had been the one who washed him the day he was born and took the veil off his face and dried it on a board and gave it to his mother to keep.

II. Dwelling Number

Caney Creek · August 1870

It was late in August, and he was nearly done. He had come down the west side of the creek since morning and had one more quarter to do before dark, and he crossed at a place he knew, below the old Ransom sugar house, where the bank was low and there was a gravel bar. The mule went into the water to its knees, and to its belly, and then it was climbing out on a bank he did not know.

There was a lane going up from the water between two rows of chinaberry trees. At the end of it were houses. He counted eleven. They were white, with galleries all across the front, and glass in the windows, and green shutters, and every one of them stood in a yard swept clean in the pattern of a broom. He had been up and down Caney Creek his whole life and there was no lane there and there were no houses like that anywhere in the county, not even the Ransoms' before the war.

The mule did not seem to mind. He let it walk.

At the first gate there was a stalk of ribbon cane in full tassel standing in the air by itself, a foot off the ground, with nothing holding it, the silver plumes stirring a little the way they do in October. A man stood on the gallery. He was tall and very black and he was dressed better than the judge, and there was a light about him, the way there is about a man standing in a door with a lamp behind him, except there was no lamp. He came down the steps and out to the gate and stood in front of the mule with his hands folded, as if Moses were somebody.

Moses did what the instructions said. He got down. He took off his hat. He said he was taking the census for the United States and he was obliged to ask some questions at every dwelling-house, and that the man

did not have to be afraid of it. Then, because he could not help it, he said: *Mister, you have got a fine house. What did you do to get it?*

Don't ask me that, the man said.

He said it the way you would ask somebody not to look in a pot that had nothing much in it. Moses asked again. He said please.

I never gave anything, the man said finally. *I didn't have anything. I didn't go to meeting much. I didn't sing. All I did, I told the truth.*

To who?

To anybody. To them, too. He nodded down the lane, toward the creek and the old sugar house and everything on the other side of the water. *Even when a lie would have done me better. That's all. That's the whole of it.*

Moses wrote him down. Dwelling number one, family number one. He asked his age and the man told him. He asked the value of his real estate and the man looked at the house as if he had never thought about it. *You'd have to ask who gave it,* he said. When it was done, Moses read the entries back to him, as the law required, so that all mistakes might be corrected on the spot, and the man listened carefully to every word and said, *I'm older than that. Put down four more years. I told them younger once, when they were selling me. I want it right.*

• • •

He went to the next gate, and the next. At every one a woman came out, and at every one she did as the man had done, came down and stood before him, and when he asked her what she had done to live in a house like that, she would not say. She looked at her hands. She said it was nothing. He asked them all a second time, and he said please every time, and in the end they told him.

At the third house it was Hagar Bell.

She was not sixty. She was not anything he could have put a number to. She had the same gap in her front teeth. She stood at the gate with the light on her, and she looked at him with his portfolio and his pen and the creek water still dripping from the mule's belly, and she laughed and said, *Moses. You found your way here too.*

Aunt Hagar, I wrote you down in March. I wrote you dead.

I know it. Write me again.

He asked her the question and she would not answer it, and he asked again.

I never had a thing to give, she said. *You know that. You know who I belonged to.* He did. Everybody on the creek did. Old Ransom would hit a person with whatever was in his hand, a cane knife, a hoe handle, a stick of stovewood, and he had once laid a man's scalp open with a sugar ladle for spilling the strike. *Every time it came up in me,* Hagar said, *I said to myself, Hagar, that man can sell your children. He can sell them tomorrow to Louisiana. You sit on it. And I sat on it. I sat on it like a lid on a pot. Forty years. That's all I did.*

The others were short. A young woman at the fifth house said that when she was a girl she had been set to mind the cane by the river road to keep the hogs out of it, and a preacher came walking by on a pass, an old man, and she broke him a stalk. That was all. At the sixth a woman said she gave a persimmon. At the seventh, a cucumber. At the eighth a girl not more than fifteen said a hatful of dewberries, to a runaway they were bringing back tied behind a horse, and she had got a whipping for it. At the ninth, a bunch of radishes. At the tenth an old, old woman who could hardly stand said that she had threaded a handful of chinaberries on a string for a little child that was crying, a child that did not belong to her, so it would have a necklace like the white girl at the big house. *That was all I did,* every one of them said at the end. *That's how I got here.*

He wrote every one of them, as if living, the way the instruction said. Name, age, sex. Occupation, which they had trouble with, because nobody there seemed to do anything, and he wrote *keeping house,* mostly. Where born: Virginia, Virginia, Maryland, Africa, Kentucky, this county. He read every entry back. They corrected him. The girl who gave the dewberries spelled her name for him, letter by letter, slowly, and watched the pen.

When he came to the column for color, he looked up at them standing in their yards with the light on them, and he could not tell, and he did not write anything there. It was the only time all summer he left it empty.

At the eleventh house there was nobody. The door was open and the floor was swept and there was a chair on the gallery. He numbered it, and drew the dash through the column the instructions said to draw for a house standing empty, and turned the mule around.

He crossed back at the gravel bar below the Ransom sugar house in the dark. When he looked back from the water there was no lane, only the canebrake going down to the creek, and a whip-poor-will, and the lamps of the quarter he had meant to do that evening, half a mile off, where people were wondering what had become of the census.

III. The Sugar Maker

The Ransom quarter · the next evening

Absalom Pleasant had been the sugar maker on the Ransom place for twenty-two grinding seasons. He was the one who stood at the last kettle of the train with the ladle in the steam and the whole quarter waiting behind him, and said when. Two hundred hogsheads a year depended on him knowing the moment the boiling syrup would strike and turn to sugar, and he knew it by the sound, people said, a change in the boil no one else could hear. There had been no sugar made on Caney Creek since the war. When Moses had come to him in June, Mr. Pleasant had given his name and his age, seventy, and when Moses asked his trade he had said *sugar maker*, and Moses had written it down, though there was nothing in the column for a man who was renting four acres of cotton on shares from his old owner's son. The instructions said that if a man could not tell intelligibly what he was, find out what he does. Mr. Pleasant had told him intelligibly.

Moses found him on his step at sundown with a pan of field peas in his lap, shelling. He sat down on the ground in front of him. He did not say good evening. He told him the whole thing, the lane, the chinaberry trees, the cane standing in the air, the eleven houses. He told him about Hagar. He got the portfolio out and showed him the page.

Mr. Pleasant could not read. He looked at it a long time anyhow, holding it out at arm's length, the way he would have held a ladle of syrup up to the light.

Mr. Pleasant, Moses said, *can a person get a house like that for a persimmon? For a bunch of radishes? For not saying a lie?*

The old man gave him the page back.

What are you asking me for? he said. *Didn't they tell you?*

Moses sat a while.

Yes, sir, he said. *They told me.*

Well then.

He went on shelling. The peas went into the pan and the hulls went into his lap. A child came across the yard to them with a gourd of water and he drank and gave the child the rest, and when the child was gone again he said it, plainly, without looking up, the way he must have said *strike* over the last kettle for twenty-two years: once, and the whole house moving at the word.

Say what's so. Don't keep a mad. When somebody asks you, give him something, if it's no more than a little. That'll carry you there. Any one of them will carry you.

That's all?

That's three. He tipped the pan to the light to see what he had. *They told you one apiece.*

IV. Family Number

Caney Creek · September 1870 and after

He told it at the brush arbor on the second Sunday in September, because Mr. Pleasant told him to, and he read the names off the page. There were people under the arbor who had known every one of them. The girl who gave the dewberries had a sister there, who had not heard her name said out loud in nine years and put her apron over her face. Afterward people stood around under the trees and did not go home, and talked low, about small things, a dipper of water, a biscuit, a lie they had not told, a blow they had not given back, the way people talk

ABOUT MONEY THEY HAD FORGOTTEN THEY HAD PUT AWAY. An old man named Ned Cotton said he had given a stalk of cane once to a preacher on the river road, before the war, and was he the one, and nobody knew.

Moses sent his portfolio up to the marshal at the end of the month, every schedule filled and signed and sworn. He kept back one sheet. He was paid by the name, and he was not paid for those.

By the grinding season of 1871 the kettles on Caney Creek were going again, with convicts leased from the state penitentiary to feed the fires, and the men at the furnace doors were wearing chains. Mr. Pleasant would not go near it. He made molasses in his own yard in a wash pot, from his own two rows of ribbon cane, and the children of the quarter stood around it in the smoke with tin cups, and he would tip the ladle to the light and listen and say *now,* and they never knew what he heard.

Moses Gallion lived to be eighty-one and taught school at Columbia for forty of those years. He was the enumerator twice more. He kept the sheet in his Bible between the Testaments, and when his granddaughter found it there after the funeral, in 1925, it was brown at the folds and the ink had gone the color of molasses, eleven dwellings on Caney Creek in his good hand, a dash through the last one, the column for color left empty all the way down. Beside the tenth house, the old woman who threaded the chinaberries, he had written something in the margin in a later ink, very small, where the instructions allowed nothing to be written: *The child was M. G.*

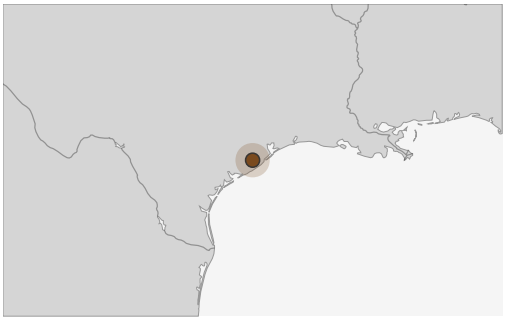
Background

The verse

> *Speak the truth, do not yield to anger; give, if thou art asked for little; by these three steps thou wilt go near the gods.*
>
> Dhammapada 224, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, the disciple known for his powers, travels to a heaven and stops at the doors of the shining mansions there. He asks

each deity how such glory was earned, and each is ashamed to say, because it was so little. One only told the truth. One, a slave in a former life under a master who would strike off a head with whatever was in his hand, kept back her anger. Others gave a stalk of sugarcane, a persimmon, a cucumber, a berry, a handful of radishes, a handful of nimb fruit. Moggallāna asks the Buddha whether such small things can win heaven, and the Buddha answers, "Why ask me? Didn't they tell you?" and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Moggallāna.



Caney Creek, Brazoria County, Texas

Brazoria County, Texas, 1870

The lower Brazos, Caney Creek and Oyster Creek were called the sugar bowl of Texas, and before the war Brazoria County made most of the state's sugar on plantations worked by enslaved people. In 1860 the county held 5,110 enslaved people, 2,027 white residents and six free Black residents. Sugar fell away after emancipation and came back, by 1871, on the labor of leased convicts; several of the old plantations later became state prison farms. In 1870 the county's voters helped elect George T. Ruby, a Black former Freedmen's Bureau teacher from Galveston, to the Texas Senate. See the Handbook of Texas on Brazoria County.

The Ninth Census took June 1, 1870 as its day and was gathered by assistant marshals going door to door. It was the first census to list every resident by name; in 1850 and 1860 enslaved people had been counted without names under their owners. The instructions to assistant marshals asked them to approach everyone "in a conciliatory manner," to read the entries back, and to describe anyone who had died since census day "as if living." Under the act of 1850 they were paid two cents for each living person and two cents for each dead one. The appointments went to Republicans, and in the South many of the assistant marshals were Black men; the census superintendent, Francis A. Walker, later judged that the count had missed several hundred thousand Black Southerners.

After the story of Mahā Moggallāna's question from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 224). The original. Quotations from the 1870 Instructions to Assistant Marshals of the Ninth Census. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.5

Hot Dish

And our spirits shall sorrow no more—
not a sigh for the blessing of rest.
— S. Fillmore Bennett, "In the Sweet By and By" (1868)

The way I heard it, at the Bluebird in Ostrander.

I. The Shoulder

Ostrander, Spink County, South Dakota · September 2002

Merle Fossum was eighty-four the year of the drought, and he still drove himself to town every morning for the mail and the markets and coffee at the Bluebird, in a white Ford pickup with the Pioneer sign half worn off the door. That September the pastures along the highway had gone the color of a paper sack. Hay was a hundred dollars a ton when you could find it, and the state agriculture secretary had said in public that the men asking it were greedy, and the men at the Bluebird talked about that and about nothing else. Gary Fossum, who farmed the home place on Turtle Creek now, had sold half the cows in August.

The exchange student had been in town three weeks. The Rotary brought one most years. This one was from Thailand, from a city called Phitsanulok, sixteen years old and slight, with a navy blazer he wore to school on Fridays with pins all down both lapels: the Thai flag, the Rotary wheel, a Twins cap, and a little enamel pheasant somebody had given him the first day. His name was Siriwat. He told people to call him Ton. Ron Hagen, who sold insurance and was Rotary president that year and the boy's first host father, called him Tom, and went on calling him Tom until June.

Exchange students were not allowed to drive, so he walked home from school along the shoulder, past the elevator and the Cenex to the Hagens' ranch house at the edge of town. On the third Thursday of September Merle was pulling out of the Cenex with a tank of gas when he saw him. He stopped the pickup on the shoulder at an angle, with the door hanging open, and got down the way old men get down, one leg and then the other, and knelt in the gravel in front of the boy and took hold of his ankles with both hands.

Son, he said. *Where have you been all this time?*

A grain truck went by and the wind of it pulled at their clothes. Cheryl Hagen's sister, going the other way, slowed down nearly to a stop.

Ton had seen people kneel like that. He had seen his grandmother kneel on the tiles of the big temple at home with her forehead nearly to the floor, and he had been a novice there himself one summer when he was twelve, with his head shaved and a robe the color of a squash blossom, and old women had knelt to him in the mornings to put rice in his bowl. He did not step back. He put his hand on the old man's seed cap and left it there.

A boy is supposed to look after his folks when they get old, Merle said. *Isn't he? This is the first I ever laid eyes on you. Get in the pickup. Come and see your mother.*

Dorothy Fossum was at the sink with the Aberdeen station on, doing the noon dishes at four in the afternoon because she had been at the church all day with the books. She was eighty-one. She dried her hands on a towel and looked at the boy in the door of her kitchen for a long time, and then she went down on her knees on the linoleum, slowly, holding the counter, and put her arms around his legs.

Where have you been? Don't children look after their mother and dad?

She made him sit. She gave him coffee cake and a glass of milk. Then she went to the phone on the wall and called her children one after the other, Gary on Turtle Creek and Janice in Aberdeen and Rick in Sioux Falls, and told each of them the same thing. *Come Sunday after church. Come and say hello to your brother.*

They came. Gary drove over in his chore coat. Janice, who was a nurse at St. Luke's, came down from Aberdeen and watched her parents all afternoon the way she watched patients, and could not find one thing wrong with either of them except this. Rick, who ran a floor of four hundred people at Citibank, got his brother out by the machine shed and asked him straight out if it was Alzheimer's. Gary said Dad had done his own taxes in April, same as every year, and Mom did the church books to the penny. They stood looking at the dry yard.

Then they went in, because their mother was waiting, and shook hands with their brother. The boy put his palms together under his chin and bowed his head to each one of them, and Rick, without thinking, put his own hands together and bowed back.

II. Hot Dish

October to December

DOROTHY WANTED HIM AT HER TABLE EVERY NIGHT. *YOU EAT here,* she said. *Your dad can pick you up after school.*

He explained it to her as well as he could. A Rotary student lived with three families in the year, a few months each, and ate where he was asked: with the members, with the churches, with the football coach, with anybody who wanted to know about Thailand. That was what he was there for. *I can't eat always in one house,* he said. *In Rotary, I go around.*

Dorothy thought about that with her hand flat on the oilcloth.

Then whoever asks you, you tell them to call me.

So it went all fall. When Cheryl Hagen had the Lutheran pastor and his wife over to meet the boy, the phone rang at three and it was Dorothy, and at a quarter to six Merle's pickup was in the drive with a roaster on the seat wrapped in a bath towel. When the Kjellsens had him out to the farm, Dorothy brought the supper. When the coach had the team over after the Faulkton game, Dorothy sent two nine-by-thirteens of tater tot hot dish and a pan of scotcheroos. Chicken and noodles over mashed potatoes. Scalloped corn. Glorified rice. Meat loaf with the ketchup baked on top. Every pan had a strip of masking tape across the lid with

FOSSUM on it in ballpoint, the way every pan in the county did, so that it would find its way home after the funerals and the church suppers. On the nights nobody asked him, Merle picked him up at the Hagens' and he ate on Turtle Creek.

People talked, of course. The Bluebird had it before the week was out. Some said the Fossums had gone soft in the head together, the way couples did who had been married that long, and some said they had always been a little different, and Hazel Kjellsen said that a woman who brought a roaster of chicken and noodles to your house every time you had company could call the boy anything she wanted.

Pheasant season opened the nineteenth of October. Ron Hagen's brothers-in-law came out from Minneapolis in a Suburban with three Labs and blaze-orange vests for everybody, and Ton walked the CRP grass west of town with them as a blocker, without a gun, because he did not kill anything. Merle drove out and sat in his pickup at the end of the strip with the window down. A rooster came up out of the grass almost under the boy's feet, copper and green and gold, with that sound like a rusty gate, and three guns went off, and the bird came down at Ton's feet and lay there kicking. He picked it up. He held it in both hands and did not know what to do with it, and it died in his hands, warm, the long tail feathers hanging down over his wrist.

Merle got out of the pickup and walked over and took the bird from him and smoothed its feathers down with his thumb, the way you would smooth a child's hair, and handed it to Ron.

On the way home Merle told him that he had not fired a gun since 1945. He had come home from Germany in the fall of that year and sold his shotgun to his brother-in-law for twelve dollars and never said why, and nobody had ever asked him. Dorothy said, from the stove, that in fifty-six years she had never once seen him raise his hand to a child or an animal, and she had never seen him raise his voice either, not even at the cattle.

That was the fall the Fossums began to sit.

After supper on Turtle Creek, while the coffee was still going, the boy would turn his kitchen chair a little away from the table and sit on it with

his back straight and his hands in his lap and his eyes closed, the way he had sat in the temple at twelve. The first time, Merle asked him what he was doing.

Sitting, Ton said.

Merle tried it the next night, in his own chair, with his seed cap on his knee. Dorothy laughed at the both of them, and within a week she had taken her apron off and was sitting too, at the end of the table, with her hands folded the way she held them in church. The three of them sat in the kitchen with the clock over the stove and the furnace coming on and going off and the wind working at the storm windows. The boy did not tell them anything to do. Afterward Dorothy would get up and cut pie.

Their children noticed it by Thanksgiving. Their mother had given the church books to Arlene Bauer. Their dad had quit turning the radio on for the markets at noon. They were quieter. Janice, who knew what to look for, still could not find it.

III. The Four-Way Test

The Legion hall · January 2003

ROTARY MET TUESDAYS AT NOON AT THE LEGION HALL, twenty-two members, hot beef sandwiches and mashed potatoes and a slice of bar. They said the Pledge, and then they said the Four-Way Test together off the banner on the wall, the way they had every Tuesday since most of them could remember. *Is it the truth? Is it fair to all concerned? Will it build goodwill and better friendships? Will it be beneficial to all concerned?* Then happy dollars, and then the program.

The program that day was the exchange student. He had a borrowed laptop and the school's projector and forty pictures. His mother and father in front of their house in Phitsanulok, his father an engineer for the provincial electric company, his mother a high-school teacher of English. His little sister in her school uniform. A rice field. A market on the river. The big temple with its gold Buddha, and himself at twelve in front of it, shaved and robed, squinting in the sun.

When he was done Ron Hagen asked if there were questions, and Duane Bauer from the elevator, who was a plain man and had been the boy's second host father since December, asked the one the whole town had.

Ton, we all know those are your folks up there on the screen. Merle and Dorothy have seen those same pictures, I'd bet. So why do they call you son, and why do you let them?

The boy did not take very long to answer.

They are calling their own son.

The room waited. Somebody's fork touched a plate.

Before, Ton said, *many times, they were my father and mother. Five hundred times. And five hundred times uncle and aunt. And five hundred times grandfather and grandmother. Fifteen hundred.* He said it the way he had said the population of Bangkok a few minutes before. *So when they see me they know me. Love comes like that. It comes from living together before, or it comes from helping now. It comes up like a lotus on the water.*

Nobody laughed, though Ron said afterward that he had been about to. Duane nodded slowly, as if he were being told the moisture in a load of corn. Then Ron thanked the boy, and they gave him a Rotary coffee mug, and everybody went back to work.

IV. Seed Corn

April and May

In March the boy moved to his third family, the parsonage behind the Methodist church, where the pastor was a woman named Karen Lindahl with two little boys and a husband who taught science at the school. The rule held. Whoever had him to supper, Dorothy brought the supper. Pastor Karen said that between Advent and Easter she had eaten more of Dorothy Fossum's cooking than she had of her own.

In April Merle told Gary which quarter to put the beans on and which to leave for corn, and then he gave Gary his tools, all of them, the good socket set and the welder and the anvil that had been his father's. He gave his chore coat to the Bauer boy, who had been wanting one. Dorothy

gave her Haviland dishes to the granddaughters, eight place settings each, and the quilts to Janice. She went to the parsonage one afternoon and sat with Pastor Karen at the kitchen table and told her which hymn she wanted, and which scripture, and that it was all written down on a card in the drawer under the phone.

It's like they're packing for a trip, Janice said to her brothers on the phone. She said it as a nurse. She meant it was a sign. But nothing showed. They were well. Their color was good. They sat in the kitchen in the evenings with the boy, when he came, and when he did not come they sat by themselves.

The peonies were starting along the south side of the house the last week of May. The boy's plane was in two weeks. On the Thursday, Dorothy brought supper to the parsonage, a roaster of Swiss steak, and stayed to eat it, and Merle had two helpings and talked to Pastor Karen's little boys about the Twins. When they left, Dorothy held the boy's face in her hands at the door and looked at him a while, and said only, *Well,* and Merle shook his hand.

Gary came in at seven the next morning for coffee, the way he did, and found them in the front room in their two recliners, side by side, with the television dark and the afghan over Dorothy's knees. The kitchen was clean. The dish rack was empty. The doctor from Redfield said it was Dorothy's heart and Merle's, and he could not say which had gone first, and he did not think it had been very long between.

The funeral home in Redfield would have sent two hearses. Gary said no. He hitched the hayrack behind his dad's John Deere 4020 and swept it out and laid a tarp on it and then a quilt, and on the day of the funeral the two caskets rode on the one hayrack, side by side, from the church to the cemetery on the hill west of town, with Gary driving the tractor in his good suit and the whole funeral walking behind.

V. The Basement

The Methodist church · the last week of May

THE CHURCH WAS FULL AND SO WAS THE BASEMENT, WHERE they had set up speakers, and people stood along the walls of both. Gary put the boy in the front pew between Janice and Rick, and nobody said anything about it. Pastor Karen read the scripture from the card in the drawer, and then they sang the hymn Dorothy had written down, which was an old one, older than the church, and which most of the people there had sung at a funeral before and knew without the book.

> *We shall sing on that beautiful shore*
> *the melodious songs of the blest;*
> *and our spirits shall sorrow no more—*
> *not a sigh for the blessing of rest.*
>
> *— S. Fillmore Bennett, "In the Sweet By and By" (1868)*

Afterward, when they had come back down from the hill, there was lunch in the basement. The long tables were covered with white paper and there were egg-salad buns and turkey buns and a dozen kinds of bars and a whole table of salads, and every pan had its strip of masking tape on the lid: HAGEN, KJELLSEN, BAUER, LINDAHL, OLSON, OLSON, LARSEN, the names of everybody who had ever eaten Dorothy's cooking.

People came by the boy where he sat. Grain-truck drivers and Rotary men and women from the circle and a man who had been in the war with Merle's brother. They took his hand and said the thing you say. *I'm sorry about your folks. Your mother was a fine woman. Your dad was the best neighbor I ever had.* He thanked each of them. He did not tell any of them that he had other folks, and when Ron Hagen started to say to somebody, *Well, now, they weren't really his,* he heard himself, and stopped, and went to get more coffee.

When the line had gone by, the boy asked Janice for a glass of water and an empty coffee cup. He set the cup on the paper tablecloth in front of him and poured the water into it slowly from the glass, in a thin stream, as his grandmother had done for his grandfather, and while it

poured he said some words in Pali, low, that nobody at the table understood. People at the other tables put their forks down. When the cup was full he set the glass beside it.

Rick asked him what it said. The boy thought, and said it in English as best he could, and it went about like this.

> *How transient are all component things!*
> *Growth is their nature and decay:*
> *They are produced, they are dissolved again:*
> *And then is best,—when they have sunk to rest!*
>
> *— Mahā-Sudassana Sutta, tr. T. W. Rhys Davids (1881)*

Rick looked at the full cup for a while. He was a man who managed four hundred people and he did not cry in front of them. He asked the boy then what nobody had asked the pastor.

Where do you think they are?

They don't come back, the boy said.

Rick's face moved, and the boy saw it, and put his hand on Rick's arm.

No. It's good. They went where there is no crying. Like your mother's song.

• • •

The women of the circle washed the dishes after, at the long steel sinks, and dried them, and sorted them out along the counter by the names on the tape, the way they always did, so that each pan would go home to its own kitchen. Dorothy's roaster went back to Gary. So did her blue Pyrex nine-by-thirteen, and Gary carried it across the basement and gave it to the boy, still warm from the dishwater, with the tape on the lid.

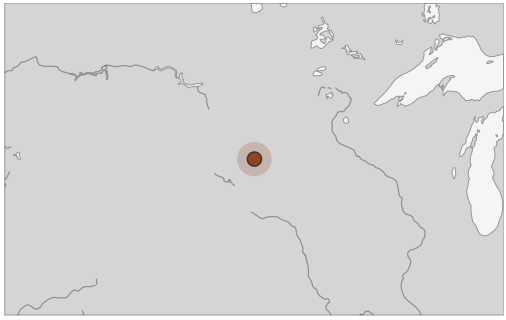
It went to Phitsanulok in his suitcase between the blazer and his Rotary mug. His mother bakes custard in it now, in the rainy season, and has never taken the tape off. The ballpoint has gone brown and the edges have curled, but it can still be read. When his little sister asks what it says, he tells her, and it is the one word of English she always says right.

Background

The verse

> *The sages who injure nobody, and who always control their body, they will go to the unchangeable place (Nirvana), where, if they have gone, they will suffer no more.*
>
> Dhammapada 225, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, an old Brahmin of Sāketa meets the Buddha at the city gate, falls at his feet, takes hold of his ankles, and calls him "dear son," scolding him for staying away so long; the Brahmin's wife does the same and tells their children to greet their brother. The Buddha says he never takes all his meals in one house, so the couple ask him to send them everyone who invites him, and they carry the food to every invitation. When the monks wonder why the Buddha lets them call him son, he says the two had been his parents, uncle and aunt, and grandparents for fifteen hundred lives each, and speaks of love that arises from living together in the past or from kindness in the present, "like a water-lily on the water." At the end of the rains the couple die together and are carried out on one bier. Mourners console the Buddha for his parents; he does not correct them, and teaches on the shortness of life. Asked where the couple have gone, he says they have gone where there is no grief. Read the full commentary story; the same tale is told in the Jātaka as the Sāketa birth story (Jātaka 68).



Spink County, South Dakota

Spink County, 2002

Pheasants are not native to the Dakotas. The first successful release in South Dakota was made in 1908, when three sportsmen let three pairs go north of Redfield, and the first official season, on October 30, 1919, was a single day in Spink County. Redfield, the county seat, calls itself the Pheasant Capital of the World. The 2002 season opened on October 19 with a bag limit of three roosters; 145,696 people hunted, slightly more than half of them from out of state (state figures). That summer was a

drought summer across the state, and the price of hay became a political fight (Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis).

The year-long Rotary Youth Exchange began in 1958. Students usually stay about ten months, live with several host families in turn, may not drink, drive, date or use drugs, and wear a blazer covered in traded pins. Rotary clubs recite the Four-Way Test, written by Herbert J. Taylor in the 1930s. At Thai Buddhist funerals, mourners perform kruat nam, pouring water slowly from one vessel into another so the dead may share in the merit; the verse on impermanence the boy says is the stanza traditionally chanted at Buddhist funerals, here in Rhys Davids's version from *Buddhist Suttas* (1881). "In the Sweet By and By" was written by S. Fillmore Bennett and Joseph P. Webster and published in Chicago in 1868.

After the story of the Brahmin from Sāketa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 225). The original. Scripture from S. Fillmore Bennett's hymn "In the Sweet By and By" (1868) and T. W. Rhys Davids's translation of the Mahā-Sudassana Sutta (1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.6

Rice Water

And what I say to you, I say to all: Watch.
— Mark 13:37

Ganito ang narinig ko, on the stairs below the hill.

I. The Grinding

Daly City, California · December 2023

THE HOUSE WAS PINK STUCCO WITH A GARAGE UNDERNEATH, like every other house on the street, and six old people lived in it who could not live anywhere else. Mr. Rolando Bautista owned it. He owned four of them, two in Daly City and two in South San Francisco, and a black Lexus, and a house in the hills above Westlake with a view of the ocean on the days when there was no fog, and people called him Boy Bautista the way they had called him that in Batangas, though he was sixty-three.

Purificación Dagdag took care of the six old people in the pink house. She was fifty-one. She had come in 2009 on a tourist visa to see a cousin and stayed when it ran out, and she had been tago nang tago ever since, hiding and hiding, which meant she could not go home. She had not gone home when her mother died in 2021, in the second year of the sickness, and had watched the funeral in Calasiao on a phone propped against the toaster. She sent money every two weeks to a daughter who was twenty-four now and a son who was twenty-one and whose faces she knew better from the screen than from memory. Everyone called her Puring.

She worked twenty-four hours a day, five days a week, and slept in the garage on a folding cot behind a curtain, between the washing machine

and the boxes of adult diapers, with a baby monitor on the pillow beside her head. Mr. Bautista paid her ninety dollars a day. She knew that this was not legal. She also knew who in the house had papers and who did not.

On the fourth night of Simbang Gabi, at nine o'clock, Mrs. Bautista came to the back door with her son carrying two big blue Igloo coolers full of glutinous rice that had been soaking since morning. Everyone called her Tita Baby. Every December she sold bibingka in the churchyard after the dawn Mass at Holy Child, up the hill, nine mornings running, the real kind, in clay pots lined with banana leaf with coals underneath and coals on top, the way they made it in front of the churches at home, and the line for it went down the steps. This year she had taken orders from three parish groups besides. She had twelve hundred cakes to make.

The grinder at my house broke, Tita Baby said. *You have the big blender. It has to be galapong by four-thirty. Junior will come for it.*

So Puring ground rice all night.

She did it in the kitchen with only the light on over the stove, so it would not wake anyone, in batches, a scoop of the soaked rice and a cup of its water into the blender and then the roar, and then the white batter poured into the stockpots on the floor, and then the next scoop. Every twenty minutes the baby monitor in her apron pocket crackled and she went down the hall. Mrs. Lim needed the bedpan. Mr. Haggerty was trying to get dressed for work, at eleven at night, for a job at the shipyards that had closed in the nineteen-seventies, and she sat on the edge of his bed and buttoned his pajamas back up and told him it was Saturday. Mrs. Ocampo was crying in her sleep in Ilocano. Then back to the kitchen, and the roar.

Her shoulders went first and then her wrists. The motor of the blender got so hot she could smell it, and she had to stop and let it cool with the jar in the sink full of cold water. Her mother had done this at home on a stone, the old gilingang bato, turning the top stone by its wooden handle with one hand and feeding the wet rice into the hole with the other, and

Puring as a girl had thought it was the hardest work in the world. Now she thought her mother at least had been allowed to sit down.

At two in the morning she was soaked through. She opened the back door to let the heat of the kitchen out and stepped onto the back step in her T-shirt, into the wind.

II. The Stairs

Two in the morning

Daly City in December is fog and wind off the ocean, and the wind came straight up the street from the Pacific and went through her wet shirt like water. She stood in it with her arms out from her sides. It was the best she had felt all night.

Behind the houses on her side of the street the hill went up steep, too steep to build on, with ice plant on it and a few cypresses bent over sideways by eighty years of wind. A concrete stairway went up the hill from the end of the street, a hundred and forty steps, to the parking lot of Holy Child at the top. On the upper side of the parking lot, apart from the church, there was a small chapel with a glass door, and in the chapel there was a gold monstrance on the altar with the Host in it, and somebody was always there. Somebody had been there every hour of every day and night since 1994, kneeling or sitting, keeping watch, one hour each. They called it perpetual adoration. Puring had never been in it. She had never had an hour.

The lamps along the stairs had been broken since the storms the winter before, when a cypress came down across them. But there were lights on the stairs now. She counted seven. They were going up, slowly, one behind the other, the way people climb a hundred and forty steps at two in the morning.

In front of them all was a small light, steadier than the others, not swinging the way a flashlight swings. She would tell this part afterward to only a few people, and only if they asked. She said that it was Mang Dado, the old sacristan, who kept the keys of the church and the book with every hour of the adoration in it, every name written in for every

hour, who had been doing it for twenty-nine years. She said he had his right hand held up in front of him with the first finger raised, as if he were telling somebody to wait one minute, and it was his finger that was shining. It was not a candle and it was not a phone. It was his finger, lit from inside, like a hand held over a flashlight, but white, and it lit every step in front of him, and the people behind him came up the stairs by it.

Puring watched them go up. At the top they crossed the parking lot and the glass door of the chapel opened and closed, and opened and closed, and the people who had been in there for the one o'clock hour came out and started down, with their phones lit.

She thought: I am up because I hurt. My shoulders hurt and my wrists hurt and I have twelve hundred cakes of rice to grind before four-thirty, and Mrs. Lim will need the bedpan again at three. That is why I am awake. Why are they awake? Nobody is making them grind anything.

In Calasiao, when she was a girl, if you saw lights moving on the dikes between the rice fields at night, it meant a man had been bitten by a snake out in the paddies and they were carrying him to the hilot. Or else somebody was dying, and they were going for the priest.

Somebody must be sick up there, she thought. One of the priests, maybe. The old one with the bad heart.

Then the monitor crackled in her apron pocket, and she went in.

III. The Cake

Before dawn

Junior came for the galapong at four-thirty in his mother's Sienna with the engine running and loaded the stockpots into the back without saying anything, and Puring stood in the driveway in her slippers and watched the taillights go up the hill.

There was some left. There always was, at the bottom of the coolers, the broken grains and the cloudy water, and in the bottom of the blender jar a coarse paste, gritty, the part that had not ground fine. Tita Baby did not want it. Tita Baby did not use anything that was not perfect, because people paid six dollars a cake.

Puring scraped it all together in a bowl with her fingers. There was not much, a cupful. She did not have an egg to spare or any sugar she could account for, so she put in nothing, only a pinch of salt and a spoon of baking powder from the cupboard. In the garage Tita Baby kept bags of charcoal for the churchyard, and Puring took eight briquettes, which she would replace, and lit them in a coffee can on the back step with a sheet of the Filipino newspaper they gave away free at the grocery. There was a packet of banana leaves in the freezer. She tore off a square and ran it under hot water until it went soft and dark and smelled like home, and laid it in a pie tin and poured the paste on it, and set the tin on the coals, and put the lid of a saucepan on top, with three coals on the lid.

It came out grey and flat and a little burnt on the bottom, the size of her palm. It was not a bibingka anybody would pay for. She wrapped it in foil and put it in the pocket of her jacket. She thought she would eat it on the way to the laundromat.

Because the sheets had to be done too. The washer in the garage had been broken since Thanksgiving, and every morning at six she carried the night's sheets down the hill in a laundry bag on her back to the laundromat on Mission Street, which opened at six, and sat with them while they washed. It was the only hour of the day when no one was calling her. She took the bag and her jacket and went out. The sky over San Bruno Mountain had just begun to go grey.

IV. The Bench

The foot of the stairs

The dawn Mass had let out. People were coming down the hundred and forty steps in the half dark in their good coats, with plates of Tita Baby's bibingka held out in front of them and steam coming off the plates, and at the bottom of the stairs, where there was a bus bench under a streetlight, Puring saw Lola Charing.

Everybody in that part of Daly City knew Lola Charing. She was eighty-six. She had come from the Philippines in 1969 on a nurses' exchange visa with twenty other girls from the same school in Manila and

had worked nights in a hospital in San Francisco for forty-one years. Nights, always, by choice: she said the night was when people were most afraid and there were fewer people there to see it. She had buried a husband and outlived two of her own girls from that school who died in the sickness, still nursing at seventy, and she still did not sleep at night. She kept the three o'clock hour in the chapel every day of the week, and had for years, and then went home and slept until noon. She was very small and wore a red wool coat and walked with a cane she mostly did not use. Her grandnephew Jun-jun walked with her, a big young man in hospital scrubs under a fleece, who was a night nurse himself in the ICU at Seton and came off his shift in time to walk her down the hill.

Lola Charing did not give sermons. She did not say much of anything. People told her things.

Puring had seen her a hundred times. When she saw her, she never had anything to give her, and on the days she had something, she never saw her. This morning she had something and there Lola Charing was, ten feet away, coming down the last of the steps on Jun-jun's arm.

Puring stopped. She thought: if she will take it without looking at what it is, I will give it to her.

She set the laundry bag down on the sidewalk. She went to Lola Charing and took the old woman's right hand and touched the back of it to her own forehead, the way she had done with her grandmother, the way you do with any elder at home. *Mano po, Lola.* Then she took the foil packet out of her pocket.

Lola, it's nothing. It's only from the bottom of the blender. Please take it, and pray for me.

Lola Charing looked at Jun-jun. Jun-jun reached inside his fleece and took out a plate. It was an old plate, white enamel with a blue rim, chipped, with the Three Kings painted on it on their camels, faded nearly to nothing. Lola Charing had carried it for years. Someone had given it to her a long time ago, and nobody now remembered who, and whatever people gave her she took on that plate.

Lola held the plate out, and Puring unwrapped the foil and put the grey cake on it, among the Three Kings.

Lola, Puring said, and found that her voice was not working well. *Whatever it is you see up there, at three o'clock. Let it be for me too.*

Siya nawa, said Lola Charing. So be it. And standing where she was, at the bottom of the stairs, she said the blessing over it, the short one, the one you say over food, and made the sign of the cross over the cake and over Puring.

Puring picked up the laundry bag. And she thought, because she could not help it: she will not eat it. She was kind to me, but she will not eat it. She will carry it a little way, and when I am gone she will give it to the crows on the wire, or to somebody's dog, and then she will go up to the parish hall where Tita Baby has the good bibingka and Mr. Bautista has sent a whole lechon from the Filipino market on Mission, the way he does every year, and she will have breakfast there.

Lola Charing looked at her. Then she looked at Jun-jun and pointed with her chin at the bus bench.

Jun-jun took off his fleece and spread it on the bench, and Lola Charing sat down on it, in the streetlight, with the people coming down the stairs around her with their plates of real bibingka, and broke the grey cake in two and ate it. She ate it slowly, all of it. She ate the burnt part on the bottom. When there was a little left she broke off a corner and gave it to Jun-jun, and he ate it, and she ate the rest.

Puring stood on the sidewalk with the laundry bag on her back and watched. The people on the stairs stopped to watch too.

What happened next was told a great many ways afterward in that parish, and Puring never argued with any of them. She said only this. She had put nothing in it but salt. There had been no sugar in that kitchen she could account for, and no coconut and no egg. But when Lola Charing broke it open there was honey in it, running, golden, so much that it ran down onto the Three Kings and Lola had to lick it off her fingers, and the smell of it came across the sidewalk in the cold, honey and toasted banana leaf. Jun-jun said for the rest of his life, to anyone who asked and to a good many who did not, that it was the best thing he had ever put in his mouth, and that he had been raised by a grandmother who made bibingka in Laguna.

When she had finished, Jun-jun poured her a cup of hot water from a thermos, and she drank it. Then she handed him the plate and looked up at Puring.

Puring, she said. *Why do you blame my people?*

Lola? I don't blame anybody.

Last night. On your back step. What did you say when you saw them on the stairs?

Puring had not said it out loud. She was sure she had not. But she told her.

I only thought, Lola. I thought, I'm awake because I hurt. My arms and my back. I can't sleep because I can't, because of the work. So why are they awake? They don't have to be. So I thought somebody up there was sick. Or dying. Like at home, when somebody was bitten in the fields.

Lola Charing nodded slowly.

You are awake because you are hurting, she said. *That is true. I know it. I did it for forty-one years. They are awake because they are watching. That's a different thing. It is the only thing.*

And then, sitting on the bus bench in her red coat with honey still on her fingers, she said the Gospel they had read in every Catholic church in the world on the first Sunday of Advent, three weeks before, in the old words she had learned it in at the convent school in Manila after the war.

> *Take ye heed, watch and pray. For ye know not when the time is. Even as a man who, going into a far country, left his house and gave authority to his servants over every work and commanded the porter to watch. Watch ye therefore (for you know not when the lord of the house cometh, at even, or at midnight, or at the cock crowing, or in the morning): Lest coming on a sudden, he find you sleeping. And what I say to you, I say to all: Watch.*
>
> *— Mark 13:33–37*

Puring heard *servants*. She heard *every work*. She heard *at midnight, or at the cock crowing*, and thought of Mr. Haggerty buttoning himself into his

pajamas for the shipyard, and Mrs. Lim calling, and the roar of the blender at two, and the lights going up the stairs.

Then something happened to her that she could not explain, standing on Mission Street at six in the morning with the sheets on her back. She thought of the rice in the coolers the night before, how when you first pour in the water it goes cloudy, all of it, every grain turning over, and you cannot see the bottom. And how if you leave it alone, only leave it, the grains go down one by one and lie still, and the water above them clears until you can see every grain.

It was like that. Nothing had been taken away. The work was the same and the garage was the same and her mother was still dead in Calasiao and Mr. Bautista still owed her whatever it was he owed her. But all of it had gone to the bottom and lay there, and she could see down through to it, every piece, and the water over it was clear and very still. She knew, standing there, that it would not go cloudy again. Not all the way. Not ever.

The people on the stairs said afterward that a good many of them felt something too, that morning, without knowing what it was, and went on to work quieter than usual.

Lola Charing got up off the bench. Jun-jun shook out his fleece and put it back on. Puring took the old woman's hand once more and touched it to her forehead, and then she went down the hill to the laundromat, and Lola went up the stairs again, slowly, on Jun-jun's arm, to the parish hall.

V. Rice Water

The parish hall of Holy Child

In the parish hall the ladies of the Couples for Christ and the Legion of Mary had heard all about it before Lola Charing got through the door. Someone had seen from the top of the stairs. Lola Charing had sat on a bus bench on Mission Street and eaten a burnt thing that Boy Bautista's TNT caregiver had cooked in a coffee can, when

there were two hundred of Tita Baby's bibingka on the tables and a whole lechon with the skin still crackling.

Kawawa naman si Lola, they were saying, poor Lola, at the coffee urn. *To eat that. She's too kind. At her age.*

Lola Charing heard it. She sat down at the end of a long table and Junjun brought her a cup of salabat, the ginger tea, and she asked the ladies what they were talking about, though she knew.

They told her, a little embarrassed.

It's not the first time, Lola said. *That I've eaten her rice.*

They waited.

I was born in Calasiao, she said. *Did you know that? Same as Puring. In 1937. My mother had no milk, and there was no money for milk, and an old woman next door who had nothing at all fed me am from a spoon. Rice water, from the top of the pot. That is what I was raised on. That old woman fed me am every day until I could eat rice.* She drank some of her salabat. *My lolo used to tell a story about that.*

And she told it to them, there at the long table, the way her grandfather had told it in Calasiao when she was a girl, with the rain on the roof.

In the old days, when the Spanish were still in Manila, a horse trader came down the north road from Ilocos with five hundred horses to sell in the city. On the road there was a big old house that had once belonged to a rich family, and the family had come down in the world until there was nobody left but one old woman, and the trader paid her to keep his horses in her yard for a few nights. While he was there one of his mares foaled. When he left, the old woman asked him for the rent, and said, *Instead of money, give me the colt,* and he did.

The old woman loved the colt like a son. She had nothing to give it, so she gave it what she had. Rice water, and the scrapings from the bottom of the pot, and grass.

Some time after, another trader came down the north road with five hundred horses and stopped at the same house. But his horses would not go into the yard. They smelled the colt, and they stood in the road with their ears back and would not go in. *Lola,* the trader said, *do you have a horse here?* And she said, *Only a colt I raise like my own child.* When the colt

came back from grazing, with its belly full of rice water, the trader looked at it and knew what it was. The colt went into its own stall, and then all five hundred horses walked into the yard as quiet as lambs.

The trader asked to buy it. *You don't sell your own child,* said the old woman. *What do you feed him?* the trader asked. *Rice water,* she said, *and scrapings, and grass. If you give him to me,* the trader said, *he will eat the best there is. He will stand on a carpet under an awning.* So she let him go. And the trader paid her for each of the colt's four legs separately, and for its tail and for its head, a purse of silver for each, six purses, and bought her a new dress and earrings and stood her in front of the colt in them. And the colt looked at her and cried. And she stroked his back and said, *I have had my pay. Go on, anak.*

The next morning the trader put a bucket of rice water in front of the colt to test it, and the colt would not touch it. *That's what you ate before,* the trader said. *Why not now?* And the colt said, *Where nobody knows who you are, there's plenty of rice water. You know me now. I won't eat it.* And the trader laughed and said he was only testing, and fed it the best there was.

In Manila he took the colt to the racetrack at San Lazaro to show it to the governor general. When he let it run it went so fast that nobody could see it at all, and he tied a red ribbon to its side so they could see where it was, and all they could see was the ribbon going around. He rode it across the fishponds at Dagupan and it did not wet its hooves. He rode it across the lotus leaves in a pond and did not sink one leaf. At the end he held out his hand, palm up, and the horse stepped up onto it and stood there with all four feet together on the trader's palm. The governor general was so pleased that he made the horse his own and gave the trader half of everything, and from that day, the trader told him to be generous, and he was, and all the islands did well.

Lola Charing put her cup down.

My lolo said the old woman in that story was from Calasiao, she said. *He said all the old women in all the good stories are from Calasiao.* She looked at the ladies at the coffee urn. *That girl fed me this morning out of the bottom of the blender. She fed me better than I have been fed in a long time.*

Then she asked Jun-jun to take her home, because it was past seven and she had been up all night.

VI. The Watch

Christmas Eve

Puring went on working in the pink house. Nothing about it changed. She ground the rice for Tita Baby every night of the novena, nine nights, and carried the sheets down the hill every morning, and slept behind the curtain in the garage with the monitor by her head.

But on the night of the twenty-fourth, at three o'clock in the morning, with the galapong poured and the blender cooling in the sink and the six old people asleep down the hall, she went out and sat on the back step in her jacket. Mr. Haggerty was asleep in his pajamas. Mrs. Lim had not called since one. Mrs. Ocampo had stopped crying in her sleep three nights before, and nobody knew why.

Up the hill the lights were going up the stairs, and in front of them the small white one, steady. The chapel door opened and closed at the top.

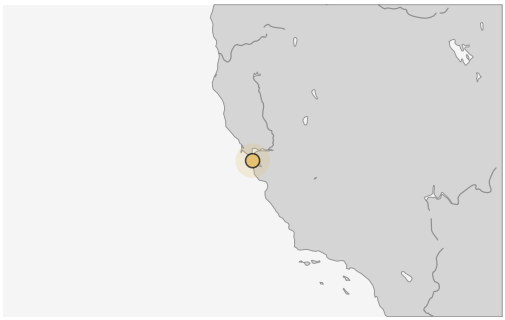
She did not have an hour in Mang Dado's book. She could not leave the house. She sat on her step with her hands in her lap and listened to the house breathing behind her, six old people asleep, and kept the hour from there. The monitor in her pocket was quiet. In the kitchen behind her, in the blue coolers, the last of the soaked rice lay on the bottom in the dark under its water, every grain gone down and still, and the water over it clear.

Background

The verse

> *Those who are ever watchful, who study day and night, and who strive after Nirvana, their passions will come to an end.*
>
> Dhammapada 226, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Puṇṇā is a slave woman in the house of a rich man of Rājagaha who is made to pound rice late into the night. Stepping outside to cool off, she sees monks walking up the mountain by a light that the elder Dabba Mallaputta, steward of lodgings, makes shine from his finger, and she supposes one of them must be sick or snakebitten. At dawn she bakes a coarse cake of rice-flour scrapings on the coals and offers it to the Buddha on the road, sure he will throw it to a dog. Instead he has Ānanda spread a robe, sits down, and eats it, while the gods squeeze heavenly nectar into it. He tells her that she stays awake because she suffers, and his monks stay awake because they watch, and speaks this verse; she is established in the first stage of awakening on the spot. When the monks marvel that he ate such poor food, he tells a birth story of a thoroughbred colt raised by an old woman on rice-water and scraps, which refuses that food once it is recognized and goes on to run over water and stand on its master's palm. Read the full commentary story.



Daly City, California

Daly City, 2023

Daly City, on the foggy ridge just south of San Francisco, has the highest concentration of Filipinos of any midsized city in North America; a third of its residents were Filipino in the 2020 census, and it is known as the "Pinoy Capital." Its Westlake tract inspired Malvina Reynolds' 1962 song "Little Boxes." Many Filipino Americans work in health care: nearly a fifth of Filipina Americans have worked as registered nurses, and during the COVID-19 pandemic Filipinos, about 4 percent of the nation's registered nurses, made up nearly a third of nurse deaths, according to a 2020 report by National Nurses United. Many others, documented and not, work as caregivers in small residential homes for the elderly. "Tago nang tago" ("hiding and hiding") is the common Filipino term for an immigrant without papers.

Simbang Gabi, the nine-day novena of Masses from December 16 to 24, began in the Spanish Philippines in the seventeenth century as a dawn Mass for farmers who had to be in the fields by sunrise; the parol, the star lantern, first lit the way to church in the dark. After Mass people eat bibingka in the churchyard: a cake of galapong, rice

soaked overnight and ground on a millstone, baked in a clay pot lined with banana leaf with coals below and above. Puring's hometown, Calasiao in Pangasinan, is famous for its own rice cake, puto Calasiao. The Gospel Lola Charing recites, Mark 13:33–37, was read at Mass on the First Sunday of Advent in 2023, December 3. It is quoted here in the Douay-Rheims version as revised by Bishop Challoner.

After the story of Puṇṇā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 226). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.7

The Touchstone

But wisdom is justified by all her children.
— Luke 7:35 (Peshitta, tr. Murdock)

Hākadhā samiʿtu, at the counter of the Royal Star Market on Dequindre.

I. The Monk

Sterling Heights, Michigan · the Ninevite fast, January 2023

Fadi Atallah sold Jeeps at a dealership on Van Dyke in Warren, and on Sunday nights, and sometimes on Wednesdays, he went live on his phone and talked about God.

He called it Faith with Fadi. He had started it during the lockdown in 2020, when the churches were closed and he was living in his parents' basement with nothing to do, and for two years forty people watched it, most of them aunts. He talked about the saints. He talked about the martyrs of the Nineveh plain, and about his grandmother, who had left Telkaif in 1977 with her gold sewn into the hem of her dress, and about the Detroit Lions, whom he considered a test of faith. He was thirty-one, handsome in a heavy-eyebrowed way, and he had the dealership voice, warm and fast, the voice that tells you there is never going to be a better time than now.

That January his cousin's wedding put him on the map. Somebody's video of Fadi leading the line dance at a banquet hall on Van Dyke, a hundred and forty people holding pinkies, went around the internet and came back again, and when it came back it had brought him nine thousand followers. Most of them were Chaldean, from Sterling Heights and El Cajon and Sydney and Toronto and Amman. Some were just people who liked the dance. On the first night of the Ninevite fast, when he

went live at nine o'clock from the parking lot of the church on Seventeen Mile, there were five hundred and twelve people watching, and he felt their attention on him like the heat off a grill.

Habibis, he told them, *it's the Ba'utha. Three days, no food till noon, no meat, no dairy, no nothing. Jonah went to Nineveh and told them to repent, and they repented, the king, the cows, everybody. Our people kept this fast for fifteen hundred years. So for three days I'm going to bring you the real thing. No Fadi. Real teachers. Tonight we start at the top.*

At the top, that week, was a monk.

Everybody in Sterling Heights knew he was in town. He was old, and he had come from Alqosh in the north of Iraq to see a doctor at Beaumont about his heart, and he was staying with a nephew on Metro Parkway, and in the evenings the nephew brought him to the parish hall and sat him in a folding chair near the coffee urn, and people lined up to kiss his hand. He was a monk of Our Lady of the Seeds, the monastery on the plain below the old monastery of Rabban Hormizd, which had been carved into the cliff above Alqosh thirteen hundred years ago. People said he had lived in one of the caves in the cliff for nineteen years, alone, coming down once a week for bread. People said he had been in the cave the whole time ISIS was in the plain below, and that the black flags had come up the road as far as the village of Batnaya and stopped, and that nobody ever knew why. People said a lot of things.

Fadi kissed his hand. He held the phone up so the five hundred could see him, a small man in a black habit with a white beard cut square, a face like a walnut, his eyes very bright.

Rabban, said Fadi. *We're live. There are five hundred people watching from all over the world. They want to hear from you. What would you tell them? What's the one thing?*

The monk looked at the phone. Then he looked at Fadi, kindly, the way you look at a nephew. Then he folded his hands in his lap and looked at nothing in particular, somewhere around the coffee urn, and said nothing.

Fadi waited. He asked again, in Sureth this time, and then in Arabic. The monk smiled a little. In the corner of the screen the comments went

up. *Is he ok. Is the sound off. Lol. Bro he's sleeping. God bless him. Ask him about the caves. Boring. Is this a prank.* The count went down to four hundred and ninety, and then four-sixty. The nephew leaned over and said, quietly, in Fadi's ear, that his uncle didn't talk much. That he hadn't really talked, the nephew said, since about 1990.

Six minutes. Fadi counted them afterward on the video. Six minutes of a man in a folding chair saying nothing at all, while the parish hall clinked and murmured around him and the urn ticked.

Okay, said Fadi finally, turning the phone around to his own face, and he smiled the dealership smile, and he ended the live. Out in the parking lot, with the snow coming down in the sodium lights, he sat in his Grand Cherokee with the engine running and felt his face burn. He had driven twenty minutes and brought five hundred people for that. The man had nothing for them. Nothing.

II. The Doctor

The parish hall · the second night

On the second night he went to Father Raad.

Everybody also knew Father Raad. He had a doctorate from the Pontifical Oriental Institute in Rome and had written a book, in English, with footnotes, about the Christology of the Church of the East. On the Tuesday of the Ba'utha he was giving a lecture in the parish hall for the young adults, and the folding chairs were set out in rows, and Fadi sat in the front with his phone on a little tripod on his knee. Five hundred and forty people were watching when Father Raad began.

Fadi wants the one thing, said Father Raad, smiling, when he saw the phone. *So I'll give you the one thing. But to understand the one thing you must understand three words.*

The three words were in Syriac. One was *kyana*, which meant nature, and one was *parsopa*, which meant something like person, and the third was *qnoma*, which Father Raad said could not really be translated at all, though he would spend some time explaining why. He explained how the Church of the East had said for fifteen centuries that in Christ there were

two natures and two *qnome* in one *parsopa*, and how the Greeks and the Latins had said two natures in one hypostasis, and how everybody had called everybody else a heretic over it for most of that time, and how in 1994 the Pope and the Patriarch of the Assyrian Church of the East had signed a common declaration saying, more or less, that they had all meant the same thing all along. He drew diagrams on a whiteboard on wheels. He quoted Babai the Great. He quoted Nestorius, and then explained carefully that he was not a Nestorian, and that nobody in the room was a Nestorian, and that Nestorius had arguably not been a Nestorian either.

It went on for an hour and fifty minutes. It was, Fadi understood dimly somewhere in the second hour, very beautiful, like watching a man build a cathedral out of toothpicks. He did not understand one word in ten. The count went down to three hundred, then a hundred and fifty, then sixty. The comments said *???* and *my brain* and *Abouna I love you but* and *what is a qnoma* and *did he say heretic*. Somebody in Toronto asked Fadi to ask Father Raad what time it was in Rome. At the end Father Raad capped his marker and asked if there were any questions, and nobody in the hall had any, and Fadi ended the live with thirty-one people watching, all of them, he suspected, aunts.

He drove home on Mound Road angry. That one had too much for them. What use was a man like that, to a car salesman in Warren, to a girl in El Cajon, to anybody with a mortgage? He might as well have done the whole thing in Syriac.

III. The Young Father

The church on Seventeen Mile · Wednesday

On the third day, after the liturgy that ends the fast, Fadi caught Father Danny in the sacristy taking off his vestments.

Father Danny was twenty-nine and had been born at Providence Hospital in Southfield and had played point guard at De La Salle. He was the one the kids liked. He said Mass fast and his homilies were short and he was, everyone agreed, the future. Fadi told him about the monk and

about Father Raad. Father Danny laughed and said Rabban was a saint and Father Raad was a genius, and Fadi said that was very nice, but he had five hundred people, and they had come for something, and they had gotten a man who wouldn't talk and a man who wouldn't stop.

Okay, said Father Danny. *Put it on.*

Fadi went live. Four hundred and eighty people were watching. Father Danny pulled his alb off over his head and folded it over his arm and looked straight into the phone.

Here's the whole thing. God loves you. Jonah didn't want to go to Nineveh because he knew God would forgive them, and God forgave them. So fast when it's time to fast. Forgive somebody this week, somebody specific. Call your mom. That's it. That's the Ba'utha. God bless.

It took forty seconds. Then he went to hang up the alb. Fadi stood in the sacristy holding the phone. The comments said *amen* and *love you Abouna* and *that's it?* and *my mom says hi* and *too short* and *fortune cookie* and *I drove here for this*, which was a lie, because the person who wrote it was in Sydney. Fadi ended the live. He found that he was angry at Father Danny too, which surprised him. A fortune cookie. Forty seconds. As if five hundred people could be handled like a customer who wanted to know the price and nothing else.

He sat in the Grand Cherokee in the church lot. It was dark already, at six o'clock, and the snow had stopped and frozen. The fast was over. He had not eaten since the night before. He was furious with all of them, the one who said nothing and the one who said everything and the one who said a little, and he did not know where to go, and so he went where he always went when he did not know where to go, which was to his aunt's store.

IV. The Store

Royal Star Market, Dequindre Road, Warren

Suhaila Kassab was not really his aunt. She was his mother's first cousin, which in Sterling Heights is the same thing. She ran the Royal Star Market on Dequindre, the road that divides Macomb

County from Oakland, a party store with a lottery machine and a beer cave and a deli counter and a wall of hot sauces she said were the best selection north of Eight Mile. She had run it alone since her husband Wadie died in April of 2020, in the first wave, in the ICU at Beaumont, while she stood in the parking lot with her phone and the nurse held the other phone to his ear. She was fifty-six. She opened the store at seven in the morning and closed it at midnight, and in between she knew everyone who came through the door, and their mothers, and what they owed her, and she told them.

There was still a plexiglass shield on the counter from the pandemic, taped at the corners, with a slot at the bottom for money. Suhaila had never taken it down. She said it kept the flu off her and the lottery players' breath, and anyway Wadie had put it up.

Fadi came in stamping snow. She looked at him over the plexiglass.

You didn't eat.

The fast's over.

I know the fast is over. I didn't ask if the fast was over. She went to the deli and came back with a pita rolled around chicken shawarma and a can of Faygo and put them through the gap at the side of the shield, and he ate standing up at the counter while she sold three scratch-offs and a pack of Newports to a man in a Carhartt jacket and asked him about his daughter's knee.

Then Fadi told her. He told her the whole thing, the five hundred, the monk, the doctor, the young father. He told her about the comments. He took out his phone, without really thinking about it, and propped it against the hot sauce display and went live, because he wanted the five hundred to hear somebody agree with him, and Suhaila would agree with him. She agreed with everybody about how bad everybody else was. Four hundred and ninety-six people were watching.

So, he said. *Three days. One says nothing. One says everything. One says forty seconds and goes to hang up his clothes. I'm angry at all three of them. Tell me I'm wrong.*

Suhaila looked at him through the plexiglass for a while. Then she looked at the phone against the hot sauce. Then she took her own phone

out of her apron pocket, which had a cracked screen and a picture of the Virgin of the Seeds on the case, and scrolled, and held it up against the shield so that he could read it.

It was her store, on Google. Royal Star Market. 3.9 stars, 212 reviews.

Read, she said.

He read. One star: *The lady never smiles. Never says hello.* One star: *Owner talks too much, I just want my lottery.* One star: *Fine I guess.* Five stars: *Best store in Warren, she asked about my mom.* One star: *She asked about my mom???* Two stars: *Too many hot sauces.* Five stars: *The hot sauces.*

Now, said Suhaila. She typed with her thumb and held it up again. It was the Grand Canyon. Four point seven. She scrolled down to the one stars and read one aloud herself, through the plexiglass. *It's a hole. Very big hole. Nothing to do.* She typed again. Lake Michigan. One star. *Too cold, can't see the other side.* She typed again. It was the cathedral in Southfield, Mother of God, Our Lady of the Chaldeans. One star. *Mass too long.* One star, right under it. *Mass too short, priest in a hurry.* One star. *Nobody talked to me.*

The Grand Canyon, she said. *God made it with his hands for a million years. Somebody gives it one star. And this one,* she said, putting her finger on the cathedral, *is my church, and I have been going there thirty years, and both these people are right, the Mass is too long and too short. It depends who says it. It depends what day.*

She put the phone back in her apron.

Fadi. You think this is new, because it's on the phone? It's the oldest thing. My father used to say, in the souk in Baghdad, the customer who wants to complain will complain if you talk to him and complain if you don't. And before my father, Our Lord. And she said it the way she said everything, standing behind the counter with her hands flat on it, without any special voice, as if she were reading a price. She said it in English for the phone, from an old English translation her priest in Baghdad had given her because it came straight from the Syriac, the Bible of their own church.

> *To what, therefore, shall I compare this generation? and to what are they like? They are like children, that sit in the market-place, and call to their fellows and say: We have piped to you, and ye did not dance; we have howled to you, and ye did not weep. For John the Baptizer came, not eating bread, and not drinking wine; and ye say: He hath a demon. The Son of man came, eating and drinking; and ye say: Behold, a gluttonous man, and a wine drinker, and one fond of publicans and sinners. But wisdom is justified by all her children.*
>
> *— Luke 7:31–35 (Peshitta, tr. Murdock)*

They didn't like John because he fasted and they didn't like Jesus because he ate. If they could find nothing wrong with Our Lord, they could find nothing wrong with anybody, and they found plenty. So. There was never anybody everybody blamed and never anybody everybody praised. Not the monk. Not Abouna Raad. Not Danny. Not you. Not me. She jerked her chin at the door. *Not the Lions.*

So then nothing counts, said Fadi. *If everybody's blamed. Five stars, one star, who cares.*

I didn't say that.

V. The Stone

Royal Star Market · near midnight

SHE REACHED UNDER THE COUNTER, BELOW THE LOTTERY MAchine, and brought out a small black stone, flat and smooth, a touchstone the size of a bar of hotel soap, and set it on the counter on her side of the plexiglass, where the phone could see it.

Fadi had seen it all his life and never asked about it. It sat next to the register, under a rubber mat, with the rolls of quarters.

My father's, said Suhaila. *From the shop.* Her father, Yousif, had been a goldsmith in Baghdad for forty years, she said, and his father before him, and in all that time he had never once asked a customer whether a piece was gold. People would come in to sell a bracelet and swear on their mothers it was twenty-one karat, and he would smile and say, of course,

of course, and take out the stone. She slid her wedding ring off her finger and drew it across the stone, firmly, once. It left a short bright streak, like a struck match. *You don't ask the man. You ask the stone. And the stone doesn't care who is the man. And my father,* she said, *tested his own gold. Every piece, before he sold it, even the pieces he made with his own hands that morning. Every day. Forty years. Because one day, he said, you will get tired, or greedy, and you will think, this time I don't need to test. And that's the day.*

She looked at the streak. Gold on black, a little line, steady.

Who praises? That's the question. Not how many stars. A girl in Sydney who watched you for forty seconds? She doesn't know you. She doesn't know the monk. She can say whatever she wants, it's like rain on the window. But somebody who knows, who watches you every day, a year, ten years, who tests you every day like my father tested the gold, if that person says you're good, then you're good. If that person says you're cheating, then you're cheating. She tapped the stone. *The monk sat in a cave nineteen years. Every day God tested him. Abouna Raad studied in Rome until his eyes went. Danny gets up at five to bring Communion to the old people in the nursing homes on Dequindre, every Tuesday, nobody sees. These people, I've been watching them. I know what they are. Who is going to give gold one star?*

She said the other one then, from the same Bible, the same plain way.

> *so that the proof of your faith may appear more precious than refined gold that is tested by fire, unto glory and honor and praise, at the manifestation of Jesus the Messiah*
>
> *— 1 Peter 1:7 (Peshitta, tr. Murdock)*

Tested by fire, she said. *Not by Google.*

Then she put the ring back on her finger, and wiped the stone with her apron, and put it under the rubber mat with the quarters, and turned to sell a bottle of Faygo Rock & Rye to a boy in a hockey jacket, and asked him how his grandfather was.

VI. Five Hundred

Warren and the world · after midnight

FADI DID NOT NOTICE THE PHONE UNTIL SHE HAD LOCKED THE door behind the last customer and turned off the beer cave lights.

It was still live, propped against the hot sauces. It had been live for fifty-one minutes. In the corner it said that four hundred and ninety-six people were watching. It was the number it had said when she began.

He picked it up. He scrolled back through the comments, and then he scrolled again, because he did not understand what he was looking at. There were no comments. From the moment Suhaila had held her phone up to the plexiglass, nobody had typed anything at all. Not *amen*, not *lol*, not *boring*, not a single heart. For fifty-one minutes, four hundred and ninety-six people in Sterling Heights and El Cajon and Sydney and Toronto and Amman and the other places, people who had left the monk and left Father Raad and complained about Father Danny, had watched a woman in an apron sell lottery tickets and talk about a stone, and none of them had said a word, and none of them had gone.

He told people afterward and they did not believe him. Then his cousin in El Cajon, who had been watching, said it was true, she had been there the whole time, she had not been able to type, she said, she did not know why, she had felt as if somebody were testing something in her and she wanted to hold still for it. A woman in Toronto wrote to him that she had called her mother for the first time in four years when the live ended. A man in Amman who had been waiting three years for a visa said he had stopped being angry at the embassy that night, and did not start again. A girl in Sydney wrote that she was sorry about the forty seconds. There were others, all that winter, more than he could keep track of, and he kept track of them in a note on his phone, until the note said four hundred and ninety-six, and then he stopped counting because it seemed like the kind of thing you should not count.

He did not do Faith with Fadi much after that. He went to the parish hall on the nights the monk sat by the urn, until the monk went home to Alqosh in the spring, and sat in a folding chair next to him, and said

nothing either, sometimes for an hour, and found that it was harder than selling Jeeps, and better. He read Father Raad's book, slowly, with a dictionary, and got as far as page ninety. He started bringing Communion with Father Danny to the nursing homes on Tuesdays, and carried the little case.

Once in a while somebody at the dealership gave him a bad review on the website, because the trade-in was low, or the coffee was cold, or he had talked too much or not enough. He read them all, and he thought about the Grand Canyon.

And on the nights he stopped at the Royal Star for a shawarma, near midnight, he would sometimes watch Suhaila, when she thought nobody was looking, take out the black stone from under the mat by the register and slide her ring off and draw it across, once, the way her father had done every day for forty years in Baghdad. She would look at the little line of gold for a moment under the fluorescent lights. Then she would wipe it away with her apron, and put the stone back with the quarters.

Background

The verses

> *This is an old saying, O Atula, this is not only of to-day: 'They blame him who sits silent, they blame him who speaks much, they also blame him who says little; there is no one on earth who is not blamed.'*
>
> Dhammapada 227, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *There never was, there never will be, nor is there now, a man who is always blamed, or a man who is always praised.*
>
> Dhammapada 228, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But he whom those who discriminate praise continually day after day, as without blemish, wise, rich in knowledge and virtue, who would dare to blame him, like a coin made of gold from the Gambu river? Even the gods praise him, he is praised even by Brahman.*
>
> Dhammapada 229–230, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the lay follower Atula takes his five hundred companions to hear the Dhamma. Elder Revata, a solitary who delights in seclusion "as a lion delights in

solitude," says nothing, and Atula leaves angry. Elder Sāriputta expounds the Abhidhamma at great length, and Atula finds it too abstruse. Elder Ānanda teaches briefly and simply, and Atula is angry at him too. At last he goes to the Buddha, who tells him that people have always blamed the silent, the talkative and the moderate, that even kings, the earth, the sun and moon and the Buddha himself are blamed by some and praised by others, and that only the praise of the wise, who examine a person day after day, counts. All five hundred enter the stream. Read the full commentary story.

Warren and Sterling Heights, Michigan

Macomb County, Michigan, 2023

Metro Detroit holds the largest community of Chaldean and Assyrian Americans in the country, around 150,000 people. Most Chaldean families trace their roots to villages on the Nineveh plain such as Tel Keppe, which the Islamic State captured in August 2014 and Iraqi forces retook in January 2017. Over the decades many families moved from Detroit's Seven Mile "Chaldean Town" to suburbs such as Sterling Heights, Warren, Troy and West Bloomfield, and Chaldean grocers came to run a large share of the region's party stores. The Chaldean Catholic Church keeps the East Syriac rite; the cathedral of its Detroit eparchy is in Southfield. In 1994 Pope John Paul II and Patriarch Dinkha IV of the Assyrian Church of the East signed a Common Christological Declaration, closing a dispute over the natures of Christ that went back to the fifth century. Three weeks before Lent, East and West Syriac churches keep the three-day Fast of the Ninevites (Ba'utha).

The monk's home is near Alqosh, below the cliff monastery of Rabban Hormizd, founded about 640 and honeycombed with hermits' cells cut into the rock; in 1859 a new monastery, Our Lady of the Seeds, was built on the plain about a mile away. Suhaila's scripture is the Peshitta, the Syriac Bible of her church, in the English of James Murdock, who in 1851 published the first English translation of the New Testament made from it. Her father's touchstone is the goldsmith's old test: gold drawn across the dark stone leaves a streak whose color shows its purity.

After the story of the lay follower Atula from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 227–230). The original. Scripture from the Syriac Peshitta New Testament in James Murdock's translation (1851). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

17.8

The New Pane

> *That neither in thoughts, nor words, nor gestures, much less in deeds…*
> *— Heidelberg Catechism, Lord's Day 40*

Aldus is het mij verhaald, in the Jonkerstraat.

I. The Six

Beverwijck, New Netherland · Sunday, the seventh of December 1659

THERE WERE SIX OF THEM, AND THE VILLAGE HAD STOPPED USing their names. Wouter the baker's son was fifteen and the tallest. Teunis was fifteen too, and Claes and Jochem were fourteen, and Gerrit, and Dirck, who was thirteen and did what the others did. If a sleigh was found on a roof, or a hog with a brewer's hat tied on, people said *the six* and went on with their work.

The river had been shut for two weeks. The last yacht had gone down to the Manhatans, the traders' rooms were empty of beaver, and there was nothing to do until spring but cut wood and go to church. That Sunday afternoon the domine was preaching the catechism sermon in the blockhouse church where the two streets crossed. The six were not at it. They had their klompen on, with straw in them, and each one had his kolf in his two hands, a stick of ash as long as his leg with a lead-weighted foot, and they were going up and down the Jonkerstraat after a ball.

The street had frozen in its ruts as hard as a hearthstone. Twelve wooden shoes on it made a noise like a mill.

Meester Harmen the glazier sat at his bench by the front window with his hands in his lap. He was past seventy and came from Holstein, and he

was a Lutheran, so the sermon up the street was not for him and no other was allowed. He had set most of the glass in Beverwijck. He heard the clatter go down the street and come back.

Pieter, he said to his apprentice, *what is that noise?*

Pieter looked out. *It is the six, Meester. They have wooden shoes on their feet and sticks in both hands and they are walking up and down on the hard ground. That is the clatter you hear.*

The old man nodded and listened.

II. Three Sounds

The Jonkerstraat · the same hour

THE GAME WAS TO DRIVE THE BALL FROM THE CHURCH TO THE bridge over the kill in the fewest strokes. Wouter had it. He was a stroke up on Teunis and had been all afternoon, and he swung for the bridge, and Teunis stepped across him and took the ball off the toe of his stick.

Wouter did not think. The kolf was already in his hands. He brought it round low and laid the weighted foot of it across Teunis's shin, above the shoe, and it made a sound like an axe going into green wood.

Teunis went down on one knee on the ice. Then he said it, loud enough for the Jonkerstraat. He called Wouter a thief, and a thief's son, whose father sold loaves two ounces light and had been before the court for it. That last part was true, and everyone on the street knew it.

Wouter did not answer him. He stood over the ball with his face gone white and still, and looked at Teunis, and went on looking. Then he hit the ball as hard as he had ever hit anything. He did not look where.

It went through the glazier's front casement, two feet from the old man's head.

The six stood where they were. Running was no use; there was nowhere in Beverwijck to run to. The door opened and Meester Harmen came out in his leather apron with the ball in one hand. In the other he had a piece of the pane the size of a playing card, green as pond water, with the lead still hanging from one edge.

He did not shout. He looked at Teunis's leg, which was bleeding into the stocking, and at Wouter's face.

You are the domine's boys, not mine, he said. *You have a book. Which of you has the fortieth Lord's Day?*

Nobody spoke. Then Dirck, who was thirteen and had been made to get it by heart that same autumn, said it to the frozen street with his cap in his hand, question and answer, in the school singsong.

> *What does God require in the sixth commandment?*
>
> *That neither in thoughts, nor words, nor gestures, much less in deeds, I dishonour, hate, wound, or kill my neighbour, by myself or by another: but that I lay aside all desire of revenge: also, that I hurt not myself, nor wilfully expose myself to any danger. Wherefore also the magistrate is armed with the sword, to prevent murder.*
>
> *— Heidelberg Catechism, Q. 105*

Thoughts, words, deeds, said the glazier. *That is the order it is written in. Where I sat, I heard it come the other way. First a stick. Then a mouth.* He looked at Wouter. *The third one made no sound at all, and it is the one that broke my window. It is not finished, either. I can see it from here.*

Wouter looked at the ground.

Keep the hand, then. Keep the tongue. Keep the thing behind the tongue. A boy who has hold of all three can carry a kolf anywhere he likes. He held up the piece of glass. *This came from Amsterdam in a crate of straw. I cannot grow another. Go home.*

III. Twenty-Five Guilders

Fort Orange · Wednesday, the tenth of December

On Wednesday the court sat in the fort. The burghers had been complaining for a month, and the glazier's casement was only the last of it. The commissary and the magistrates had it written into the book and read out in the street: that the playing of kolf along the streets did great damage to the windows of the houses and put people in danger

OF BEING HURT, AND THAT IT WAS FORBIDDEN TO ALL PERSONS from that day, under penalty of twenty-five guilders for each one found doing it.

Twenty-five guilders was more than six kolven and twelve klompen would fetch, with the six boys thrown in. That was how it always went with the six. Each thing they did turned into a rule for everybody.

The court could do nothing about the rest of it. The magistrates had no ordinance for a boy's face.

• • •

Wouter came to the glazier's door on Thursday morning by himself, without his stick. He did not say why he had come, and Meester Harmen did not ask him. The casement lay flat on the bench with the broken diamond cut out of it. The old man had a new one ready, scored and snapped from the last sheet in the crate.

Wash your hands. Hold it there, by the edges. Do not press, and do not let go.

Wouter held it. The glazier bent the soft lead around the pane with his thumbs and ran the hot iron along each joint, a hand's width from the boy's fingers. It took a quarter of an hour. Outside, Teunis went by toward the bridge with a load of firewood on his shoulder, limping. He looked in at the window as he passed. Wouter saw him, and his hands stayed where they were.

When the frame was hung again the new pane was easy to find. The old ones were green and full of small bubbles. This one was nearly white, and the street showed through it plain.

Background

The verses

> *Beware of bodily anger, and control thy body! Leave the sins of the body, and with thy body practise virtue!*
>
> Dhammapada 231, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Beware of the anger of the tongue, and control thy tongue! Leave the sins of the tongue, and practise virtue with thy tongue!*
>
> Dhammapada 232, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Beware of the anger of the mind, and control thy mind! Leave the sins of the mind, and practise virtue with thy mind!*
>
> Dhammapada 233, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The wise who control their body, who control their tongue, the wise who control their mind, are indeed well controlled.*
>
> Dhammapada 234, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is a few lines long. The monks of the Group of Six, whose misbehaviour is the occasion for a great many of the monastic rules, put on wooden shoes, take a staff in each hand and tramp up and down on a flat rock. The Buddha hears the clatter and asks Ānanda what it is; told, he lays down that a monk should control his deeds, his words and his thoughts, and speaks the four verses. Read the full commentary story.

Beverwijck (Albany), New York

Beverwijck, 1659

Beverwijck, the fur-trading village beside Fort Orange on the upper Hudson, is now Albany, New York. On December 10, 1659, its court, "having heard diverse complaints from the burghers of this place against the practice of playing golf along the streets, which causes great damage to the windows of the houses and also exposes people to the danger of being injured," forbade the game in the streets under a penalty of twenty-five guilders a person (Fort Orange Court Minutes, tr. Charles Gehring). The game was kolf, played with a weighted stick and a ball; the ordinance is often cited as the first mention of golf in America. The six boys, the glazier and his window are invented.

The Reformed church was the only public worship the colony allowed, and Lutherans, of whom the upper Hudson had a good many, were refused a preacher of their own through the 1650s. Reformed children learned the Heidelberg Catechism (1563) by heart, and its fifty-two Lord's Days were preached through at the Sunday afternoon service. The answer quoted is from the old English version long used by the Reformed Church in America.

After the story of the Group of Six from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 231–234). The original. Scripture from the Heidelberg Catechism in its traditional English version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 18

Impurity

18.1

Neat's Tongue

I Sayd, I will look to my wayes,
lest I sin with my tongue.
— Psalm 39:1, Bay Psalm Book (1640)

As I am credibly informed, at Springfield upon Connecticut River.

I. Flesh

Springfield upon Connecticut River · July 1691

Elias Cole killed beasts for fifty-five years. He came up the river at fifteen in the year the town was planted, when it was still called Agawam and there were still Indian cornfields on the meadows, and somebody put a knife in his hand that first winter and he never set it down. He killed for the families who could not bring themselves to do it and for the ones who could not spare the day. He killed the fat oxen and the barren cows in November, and hogs by the hundred, for the salt barrels that went down the river on the flatboats to Hartford, and from Hartford to Boston and the sugar islands, where they fed men he would never see. He was paid in wheat, in wampum when there was wampum, in shillings when there were shillings, and always in the best piece of whatever he had killed, which he carried home himself under his arm.

He ate it with his wife and his son at his own board and sold the rest. He would not eat without flesh. Samp, hasty pudding, rye-and-Indian bread, pease, the sallet greens his wife grew by the door: none of it would go past his teeth unless there was meat on the trencher beside it. The town said Elias Cole would starve to death in a cornfield.

The meetinghouse stood across the lane from his door, and the minister's house beside it. In fifty-five years Elias Cole never gave the minister

so much as a spoonful of anything. He paid the minister's rate because the town would have taken his cow if he had not, and not a penny over it. In December, when the other men carted the minister his winter wood, Elias sat on his doorstep whetting his knife and watched the sleds go by. He went to meeting because the law said he must, and sat on the back bench with his hat on his knees, and slept.

He had married late, the second time, a girl named Mercy from Windsor who was nearly twenty years younger than he was, and they had one child, a boy, born two springs before the war, and she named him Return. She had one book, her mother's psalm book, printed at Cambridge in the Bay the year she was born, and she taught the boy his letters out of it. He could read the psalms before he could read anything else. He knew them the way he knew the smell of the yard behind the house, the salt and the blood and the flies.

On a hot afternoon in July, in the year 1691, Elias sold the last of a heifer from the tail of his cart, gave Mercy a piece of the brisket to boil for his supper, and went down the bank to the river to wash the blood off his arms, as he did every evening in summer.

While he was gone Goodman Hale came to the door. He had lived three lots down for thirty years and was the nearest thing Elias had to a friend. His wife's brother had come down from Hadley without warning, with two boys, and there was nothing in the house but samp.

Let me have a little of the beef, Mercy. I'll pay him tomorrow.

There's none to sell. He sold the last of it at the cart and he's gone down to wash.

Don't send me off. If there's a piece in the house, let me have it.

There's not a piece in the house but what he set by for his own supper. You know he won't eat without it.

Goodman Hale stood in the doorway a while, thinking. If that was Elias Cole's supper, then Elias Cole would never give it to him, not for money, not for Hadley, not for anything. So he stepped past her to the board where the brisket lay salted for the kettle and took it up in his two hands and went off down the lane with it.

Elias came up from the river with his shirt over his shoulder. Mercy set before him a dish of samp with purslane and a little vinegar, which she had made as well as she knew how.

Where's the flesh?

There is none, husband.

Did I not give you a piece of brisket before I went down?

She told him. Hale, and the brother from Hadley, and the two boys, and the brisket going down the lane in Hale's hands.

Then I'll not eat. Take it away.

What's to be done, Elias? Eat the samp.

I will not.

He made her take the dish off the board. Then he took his knife down from the peg and went out the back.

His ox was tethered in the yard behind the house, an old red ox called Broad that had drawn his cart for eleven years. Elias walked up to it and put his hand into its mouth and pulled out its tongue and cut it off at the root. Then he came back into the house with it and laid it on the coals and turned it with the knife until it was done, and had Mercy bring the samp back, and laid the tongue on top of it, and sat down to his supper.

He ate a spoonful of the samp first. Then he cut a piece of the tongue and put it in his mouth.

In that moment his own tongue split in two and fell out of his mouth into the dish.

That is how Goodwife Hale told it, who had come up the lane to say her husband was sorry and saw it through the open door. That is how Mercy told it, until she died. Blood came out of him in a stream onto the board and down his shirt. He stood up and knocked the bench over and went out into the yard and down on his hands and knees in the dirt, and he crawled, and he bellowed. He bellowed like an ox. Out by the fence the ox was bellowing too, with its mouth full of blood, and you could not tell the one sound from the other.

Return was seventeen. He stood in the back door and watched.

His mother took him by the arm. *Son, look at him. Look what's come down on him. That is the hand of God, and it's on this house, and it will come*

down on your head too if you stay under this roof. Don't stay for me. Go. Go now.

She put her mother's psalm book in his hands, and three pine-tree shillings out of the crock on the shelf, and pushed him out the front door into the lane, and shut it.

He went east on the Bay Path that same night, walking, and did not stop until it was light.

Elias Cole crawled about his yard for three days, bellowing, and the whole town came to look at him over the fence. The minister came across the lane and prayed over him in the dirt. The selectmen talked of presenting him at the county court, for the colony's old Body of Liberties had said, fifty years before, that *No man shall exercise any Tirranny or Cruelltie towards any bruite Creature which are usuallie kept for man's use*. But on the third day he died, and there was nobody left to present. The ox died the same night. A minister in Boston who collected such things heard of it the next year and wrote it down among the remarkable judgments of God upon sinners.

II. The Ring

Boston · 1691–1699

It is ninety miles by the Bay Path and Return walked it in five days. He slept in barns and once in a hollow log. He ate what women gave him at back doors, and when they asked whose boy he was he said he was going to his uncle in Boston, and he had no uncle in Boston. He did not open his mouth for anything else.

Boston smelled of tar and fish and the sea, and it had more people in it than he had known were in the world. He went up and down the streets near the Town House for a week, sleeping under a wharf, and on the seventh day he stood in front of a goldsmith's window watching a man inside work the bellows at a little furnace, and the man came out and asked him what he wanted.

The goldsmith was Isaac Lowde. He needed a boy. He asked if Return could read, and Return took the psalm book out of his shirt and read him

the first psalm that came, and Lowde nodded and asked whose boy he was, and Return said nothing at all.

Well, said Lowde, *a boy who can't be made to talk is a boy who won't tell the customers what's in the strongbox.* And he bound him for seven years.

The next summer they hanged people at Salem for things a great deal less than what Return had seen, and he heard the men in the shop talk about it over the counter, the spectres and the marks on the body, the hand of God, the sins of the fathers, and he kept his head down over the bench and said nothing. He learned to work the bellows and to keep the charcoal at the right red. He learned how the dross rises on the silver in the crucible and how you blow it off and blow it off until the metal lies clear as a mirror and you can see the roof beams in it. He learned to raise a porringer out of a flat disk with the hammer, to draw wire, to chase and to engrave. In the third year Lowde set him to rings.

When a man of any substance died in Boston, his family gave rings to the mourners: plain gold bands with black enamel let into them, and on the outside a little death's head or a coffin or a skeleton lying down, and round the hoop the name of the dead and the date and the words MEMENTO MORI. A judge in the town was known to have a drawer full of them from the funerals he had walked in. A rich man's widow might order forty.

One morning in the fourth year Lowde went out to Roxbury on business and told Return, at the door, that a merchant's widow on the Mill Creek wanted twenty rings for Thursday. Here were the names and the date. A death's head on each, and the motto. *Cut the first one and I'll look at it tonight.*

When Lowde came home after dark there were twenty rings in a row on a square of black cloth by the window, finished, the enamel set, every skull grinning the same small grin, every letter clean. Lowde picked one up and held it to the candle and turned it for a long time, and put it down.

Wherever this boy goes, he said to his wife that night, *he'll eat.*

When the seven years were out he gave Return his daughter Hannah.

III. Forty Years

Boston · 1699–1736

Return Cole kept a shop of his own for nearly forty years. He had three sons and two daughters and he named the girls Mercy and Hannah. He made porringers and spoons and tankards and the clasps for Bibles and the buckles for shoes, but mostly he made rings, because he was the best in the town at rings and everyone knew it. He did not keep count. Hannah once tried to reckon it from the books and stopped somewhere above three thousand. Three thousand little skulls. Three thousand times he cut MEMENTO MORI round a gold hoop with a graver no bigger than a darning needle, and never once in all those years did he read the words.

He was civil to everybody and spoke to nobody. He went to meeting because the law still said he must, and sat on the back bench with his hat on his knees. He never owned the covenant. He never gave the minister anything beyond his rate. When Hannah asked him why not, he said the minister had a salary, and went back to his bench. His children learned the catechism at their mother's knee and recited it to him on Sunday evenings, and he listened with his eyes on the fire. When they asked about their grandfather he said *He was a butcher. He died.* When they asked how, he said *Suddenly.*

He ate meat when it was set in front of him and did not want it. He would not have a tongue in the house, of any kind, salt or fresh. Hannah thought it was a fancy. She never knew.

Once, in the hard winter of 1717, when the snow came up over the doors in Boston and men walked to meeting on top of it, a customer told in the shop how a man in the country had cut his beast's throat in a rage and the beast had lived and walked about bleeding, and everybody laughed at the stupidity of it, and Return put down his graver and went out the back and stood in the snow in his shirtsleeves until Hannah came and brought him in.

The sons grew up and learned trades. Isaac was a cooper. Thomas was a joiner. Joseph, the youngest, went to sea for two voyages and came

home and said he would rather have land. There was land to be had up the country, in the river towns, more than there was in Boston, and in the year 1728 the three of them went up the Bay Path together with their wives and took up lots in a new precinct on the Chicopee, a few miles above Springfield, and set up their households there. Return did not go to see them off. He did not tell them their grandfather had lived and died a few miles from where they were going. They did not know it until much later.

In the winter of 1734 and 1735 the awakening came down the river from Northampton. It went from town to town that winter like a fever, people said, but a fever that left them better, and it came to the new precinct on the Chicopee, and Isaac and Thomas and Joseph Cole were among those it found. They wrote to their father that spring, and Isaac wrote again in the summer. Return read the letters at his bench and put them in the drawer with the ring blanks and did not answer.

Hannah died in October of 1736. After the funeral, at which he gave away twenty-two rings of his own making, Return went back to his bench the next morning and sat there, and did not light the furnace.

Up on the Chicopee, his sons talked it over by the fire. *Our father is an old man now. He's alone. He has nobody to get his dinner.* So in January Joseph came down the Bay Path with a horse and a sleigh, and loaded the old man's tools into it in their chest, and the psalm book, which had come apart at the back, and drove him up to the river.

IV. The First Day

The new precinct on the Chicopee · January 1737

He was sixty-two years old. He had walked down that road at seventeen and he was carried up it at sixty-two in a sleigh under a bearskin, and it took four days, and he did not say anything the whole way except about the cold.

His sons had talked something else over by the fire. Their father had never in his life done one thing for God that he was not made to do by law. He was old. Soon he would go where they could not follow him, and

he would go with nothing. They could not give him a heart. But they could do what was in their power, which was to keep a feast in his name, as people do for the poor, and let him have whatever good there was in it.

So they asked the minister to dine at Isaac's house on the Thursday, and the deacons, and every soul in the precinct who could get there through the snow.

The minister was a young man named Jonas Thorne. He was twenty-six, Harvard College, and he had been ordained in the new meetinghouse only in October, when the frame was barely closed in. He was thin, and he had a cough that winter that people worried over. He was not a great preacher. He read his sermons in a light voice with his eyes down. But in the year he had been on the Chicopee he had sat up with every sick person in the precinct, and he could not walk the length of the road without being asked in.

The women of the three houses cooked for two days. There was a goose, and a boiled dish of pork and cabbage and turnips, and pease, and rye-and-Indian bread, and an Indian pudding that had been in the oven all night, and pumpkin, and dried-apple pies, and cider. They put the old man at the head of the board in Isaac's chair with his back to the fire, and twenty people ate at two tables, and the children ate standing.

When the meat was done and the boards were cleared, Isaac stood up.

Mr. Thorne. This dinner is given in our father's name, that whatever good is in it may be his. Will you return thanks for him.

The minister did not stand. He turned on the bench so that he was facing the old man at the head of the table, and looked at him for a while, and spoke to him as plainly as if they were alone.

Mr. Cole. You are an old man. You are a leaf in November that hasn't let go of the branch yet, and it will. They're waiting for you. You know that better than I do; you've made the rings. You're going on a journey and you have laid up nothing for it. Not a barrel. Not a biscuit. He coughed into his sleeve and waited until it passed. *Get yourself a refuge. When the river comes up in the spring, every man on the meadows makes for the high ground and doesn't stop to finish his supper. Make for the high ground, Mr. Cole. Be wise. Don't be a fool.*

Then he asked for a psalm book, and somebody brought him the old man's, from the chest, because it was nearest, and he opened it at the ninetieth psalm and gave the line to the deacon, and the deacon lined it out, and the two tables sang it after him, a line at a time, in the slow old way, with the children standing at the wall.

Threescore & ten yeares are the dayes
of our yeares which remaine,
& if through strength they fourscore be,
their strength is grief & paine:
For it's cut off soone, & wee flye
away: Who is't doth know
thine angers strength? according as
thy feare, thy wrath is so.
Teach us to count our dayes: our hearts
so wee'l on wisdome set.

— Psalm 90:10–12, Bay Psalm Book (1640)

Return Cole did not sing. He sat with his hands on the board. He had one ring on his own hand, his wife's mourning ring, which he had made in October with her name round it, and in the middle of the psalm he looked down at it, the way a man looks down at a thing he has been carrying for so long he has stopped knowing it is there.

MEMENTO MORI, it said. He read it.

It was not much. A man in the meadows looking up, once, at the sound of water. But his daughter-in-law, who was watching him, said afterward that she saw his face change at the board like a field when the shadow of a cloud goes off it, and that he sat there after the singing with his eyes open and wet, and did not wipe them, and let the children see.

V. The Second Day

Isaac Cole's house · the next day

THE SONS DID NOT ASK HIM WHAT HAD HAPPENED. THAT NIGHT they asked Mr. Thorne to come again the next day, and he came, through new snow, with his cough worse. There was not so much to eat the second day, because they had eaten most of it the first, and it did not matter. This time the brothers said it plainly, before the meal and after it: *this is for our father, Mr. Thorne. Not for us. For him only.*

So when they had eaten, the minister turned again on the bench to the old man.

Mr. Cole. You are very far along in years. You are come almost to the door. Between here and there, there is no inn on the road, no house to put up at, no place to stop and get your breath. And you have nothing in your bag. He was quiet a while. *You know how they take the dross off silver. You know it better than I do. Blow it off. Blow it off again. Quickly, while there's fire. Get up on the high ground, Mr. Cole, and there's a place where the water doesn't come.*

Then he reached for the old man's psalm book, which had been left on the shelf since the day before, and held it shut on his knee. He had sat up with it half the night, his landlady said afterward. He said the words from memory, in the old book's own wording.

> *Heare my pray'r, Lord, hark to my cry,*
> *be not still at my tears:*
> *for stranger, & pilgrim with thee,*
> *I 'me, as all my fathers.*
> *O turne aside a while from mee,*
> *that I may strength recall:*
> *before I doe depart from hence,*
> *and be noe more at all.*
>
> *— Psalm 39:12–13, Bay Psalm Book (1640)*

As all my fathers, said Return Cole.

It was the first thing he had said at either table. Everyone turned. And then the old man began to talk, in a low voice, the way water begins to

come over a dam that has held for a long time, a little at first, at one low place, and then all along the top. He told them about Springfield. He told them about the house across the lane from the meetinghouse, and the knife on the peg, and the salt barrels going down the river. He told them about Goodman Hale and the brother from Hadley and the piece of brisket. He told them about the ox, whose name was Broad. He told them all of it, at the table, with the children standing at the wall, and his sons heard for the first time what had happened to their grandfather, a few miles down the river, forty-six years before. He told them that he had walked to Boston to get out from under it, and that he had been waiting for it ever since, every day, at the bench, with his tongue held tight against the roof of his mouth so it would not fall. That he had been waiting for it to come down on his head.

It did not come down, said Mr. Thorne.

No.

It was never going to come down on you, Mr. Cole. It was his. All you had to carry up this road was your own.

The minister had given him the whole of it, the way a father puts a whole spoonful into his own mouth to show a child how. The old man took the piece of it that fit his mouth, the way a child does. It was enough. His sons said afterward that it was like watching the ice go out of the river in April, all at once, after a long time of nothing, with a sound like a shot. The people at the second table said they had their own good of it too, and some of them were in the church by spring.

• • •

That night Return Cole went out to Isaac's barn in the dark with a lantern. Nobody saw him go but his granddaughter Hannah, who was nine, and who followed him in her stocking feet across the snow and stood in the barn door.

Isaac kept two oxen, a brindle pair. The old man hung the lantern on a nail and stood in front of the near one for a long time, and the ox looked at him, and breathed on him, two long plumes of white in the cold.

Then he held out his hand, open, palm up, the way you hold out salt.

The ox put out its tongue and took his hand into it, rough and warm and wet, the whole of his palm and his fingers and his wife's ring, and licked it, slowly, over and over, and he stood there and let it.

Background

The verses

> *Thou art now like a sear leaf, the messengers of death (Yama) have come near to thee; thou standest at the door of thy departure, and thou hast no provision for thy journey.*
>
> Dhammapada 235, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Make thyself an island, work hard, be wise! When thy impurities are blown away, and thou art free from guilt, thou wilt enter into the heavenly world of the elect (Ariya).*
>
> Dhammapada 236, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Thy life has come to an end, thou art come near to death (Yama), there is no resting-place for thee on the road, and thou hast no provision for thy journey.*
>
> Dhammapada 237, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Make thyself an island, work hard, be wise! When thy impurities are blown away, and thou art free from guilt, thou wilt not enter again into birth and decay.*
>
> Dhammapada 238, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a cow-killer of Sāvatthī will not eat his rice without meat. When a friend carries off his supper, he cuts the tongue out of a living ox, and as he eats it his own tongue splits and falls into the dish; he crawls about his yard bellowing like an ox until he dies. His terrified son flees to Takkasilā, is apprenticed to a goldsmith, marries the master's daughter and lives out his life without a single good work. His sons, who have become followers of the Buddha, bring him home in his old age and give alms in his name two days running, and each day the Buddha thanks the old man with two verses, telling him he is a withered leaf with no provisions for the journey and must make himself an island. Read the full commentary story.

Springfield and Boston, Massachusetts

Springfield and Boston, 1636–1737

Springfield was founded in 1636 by the Puritan fur trader William Pynchon as Agawam Plantation, on land bought from the Agawam people. The Pynchons traded furs, grain and salt pork; pork packed in hogsheads went down the Connecticut River and, in time, as far as the West Indies. In 1675, during King Philip's War, most of the town was burned. The colony's first law code, the Massachusetts Body of Liberties of 1641, included the clause Elias Cole broke, often called the first animal-protection law in America. The psalms in the story are quoted from the Bay Psalm Book, printed at Cambridge in 1640, the first book printed in British North America, in its own spelling (with the long s modernized); eleven copies of that first edition survive.

In Boston, goldsmiths made the gold mourning rings that families gave out at funerals, decorated with skeletons, coffins and winged death's heads in the memento mori tradition: remember that you must die. Return Cole arrives the year before the Salem witch trials and lives through the Great Snow of 1717. The awakening that reaches his sons began in Jonathan Edwards's Northampton congregation in 1734 and spread to some twenty-five towns of western Massachusetts and central Connecticut before it waned in 1737, a forerunner of the First Great Awakening. The new precinct on the Chicopee, its minister and the Cole family are fictional.

After the story of a cow-killer's son from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 235–238). The original. Scripture from the Bay Psalm Book (Cambridge, 1640). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.2

The Drop Corner

To the many duties ever near you now be true,
Brighten the corner where you are.
— Ina Duley Ogdon, "Brighten the Corner Where You Are" (1913)

This is how it came down the route, on Larkspur Road.

I. Grass

Cranston, Rhode Island · June 1966

Norman Tefft had been a checker in the drafting room at Brown & Sharpe for twenty-six of his thirty-eight years there. Other men drew the parts and he went over their sheets with a red pencil. He retired in 1964, when the company moved down to North Kingstown, and his wife died the winter after. Since then he had kept the house on the corner of Larkspur Road and Wheelock Avenue the way he had kept other men's drawings. The lawn was edged with a spade along a stretched string.

Beyond his lot line, in the point where the two streets met, lay a wedge of ground that belonged to the electric company. A streetlight stood on it. At five every morning a green station wagon stopped under the light and a man put out seven bundles of the *Providence Journal*, and by ten past there were seven boys kneeling around them. Mr. Tefft knew the boys by their faults. They left bundle wire. They cut across his corner. In 1965 he had telephoned the paper about them four times, and once he had stood over a boy named Dennis until every rubber band was picked up out of his pachysandra.

He had not slept past half past four since Eleanor died. One morning in the first week of June he was standing at the kitchen window with his coffee when the smallest of the boys got up from his knees. The boy was ten or eleven, and the strap of his canvas bag had been let out for somebody taller. He started toward his bicycle with thirty papers in the bag, and the bottom of it trailed through the grass. Nobody had cut the wedge that year. The timothy and chicory stood past the boy's knees and the dew was heavy on all of it. Mr. Tefft watched the canvas go dark a hand's breadth up.

He knew what that meant on the porches at the far end of the route. He had made one of his four telephone calls about a wet paper.

That wants cutting, he said to the window.

The next morning, when the boys had gone, he took the Toro across his lot line for the first time in nineteen years. He mowed the wedge twice, the second time crosswise, raked it, and carried off what he raked. By eight o'clock it was as flat and clean as a board with fresh paper on it.

II. Sand

The morning after

WITH THE GRASS OFF, THE GROUND SHOWED FOR WHAT IT WAS. Under the streetlight, where the bundles had landed every morning for years, there was no turf at all. There was a bare place the size of a dining table, gray, and fine as flour in dry weather.

He stood at the window. The boys knelt in it and folded, three folds and a tuck, and stood the folded papers on end against their knees. A bag set down sent up a little smoke of dust. The tall boy slapped at the seat of his dungarees. A front page lay face down a moment and came up with the print of the ground on it.

Sand, said Mr. Tefft.

He had most of a yard of washed mason's sand behind the garage, left from the patio he had laid in 1961. He wheeled four barrows of it across before noon and spread it two inches deep with the back of a rake, and tamped it, and struck it off level with a length of two-by-four.

III. Shade, and Then a Roof

July and August

In the second week of July the nights stopped cooling. At half past five one morning the sun was already over the maples across Wheelock Avenue and the thermometer on his garage stood at eighty-one. The boys had their shirts off and tied around their waists. The sweat ran down their arms as they folded, and the newsprint came off black on their forearms and went from there onto the papers.

That afternoon he set four cedar posts in the sand, eight feet on centers, and stretched over them the canvas fly from the tent he and Eleanor had taken to Maine each August until her knees gave out.

The fly served for six weeks. Then, on a morning late in August, it rained out of the northeast, the kind of rain that travels sideways. He watched seven boys crowd toward the middle of a square of dry sand that grew smaller as he looked. The bundles on the windward side took the water through their wrappers. The small one, whose name he had learned was Stevie, put his own body between the rain and his bag.

Mr. Tefft went down cellar, where his drawing board had stood under a sheet since 1964. He took off the sheet and taped down a clean piece of vellum. He drew the thing at an inch and a half to the foot: three walls and a shed roof on the four cedar posts, the open side to the south, away from the weather. He drew a bench along the back wall at twenty-eight inches and a second, lower, at twenty-two. He had never measured a boy. He had only watched where their elbows came when they folded.

He checked the sheet when it was done and found nothing to mark. He wrote to the electric company, and they answered in nine days that they had no objection to a temporary structure. It took him eleven mornings to build. He started each day after the boys had gone and had his tools put away before the afternoon *Bulletin*. The roof was green corrugated fiberglass, so there would be light under it.

IV. The Cookout

The Saturday after Labor Day

WHEN THE LAST SCREW WAS IN HE THOUGHT THERE OUGHT TO be something to mark it. He asked the boys for Saturday noon, all seven, and he asked the man with the station wagon.

The man's name was Earl Aldrich. He was the district man for the *Journal* on that side of Cranston. He was fifty-eight and had put out bundles in the dark for twenty-two years, and the boys minded him without his ever raising his voice. They said that he never forgot a route or what a boy was owed, down to the penny.

Mr. Tefft cooked frankfurters on the patio and carried them across in a roasting pan. There was coffee milk in the two-gallon picnic jug, and a sheet cake from the bakery in Garden City, and Eleanor's potato salad made from the card in her handwriting. He sat Mr. Aldrich on the upper bench and the boys where they liked, some inside and some out on the sand. Because it was an occasion he had brought out the silver chest. He had not opened it since the funeral. Every fork in it had gone the color of a stovepipe.

When they had eaten he took Mr. Aldrich's paper plate from him and stood there holding it.

I want to tell you how this came about, he said. He told it from the beginning and left nothing out, the way he would have read off the changes on a sheet. *I was at my window in June and saw that boy's bag go through the wet grass, so I cut the grass. With the grass off I saw the dirt, so I put down sand. In July I saw them sweat, so I put up the fly. Then it rained, and I drew this.* He stopped. *I ought to say the rest. I called your office about these boys four times last year.*

Five, Mr. Aldrich said. *I took the calls.*

He had one of the black forks in his hand. He took out his handkerchief, wrapped it over his thumb, and rubbed the back of the handle, slowly, in one place. A spot the size of a dime came up white.

My mother worked in the case room at Gorham, he said. *She sewed the flannel bags the silver went home in. She used to say tarnish isn't dirt. Nobody put it*

there. It comes out of the air, and the silver takes it up by itself. And she said you never do the chest. You do a piece. She did one every night after supper, and by the time she had got around to the last, the first was wanting it again.

He rubbed a while longer.

She took me to hear Billy Sunday in the tabernacle in the fall of 1918, just before the influenza shut it. I was ten years old. I don't recall one word the man said. I recall the whole tabernacle singing this.

He did not sing it. He said it over, in the voice he used for counting out bundles.

> *Do not wait until some deed of greatness you may do,*
> *Do not wait to shed your light afar;*
> *To the many duties ever near you now be true,*
> *Brighten the corner where you are.*
>
> *— Ina Duley Ogdon, "Brighten the Corner Where You Are" (1913)*

You did your grass in June, Mr. Aldrich said. *Then the sand, and the canvas, and now you have a roof. I would say you have been at it since June, Mr. Tefft, a piece at a time, and it wasn't only this corner you were doing.* He laid the fork down on the bench with the bright place up. *Dennis. Pick up those plates.*

V. A Piece a Night

That evening, and after

THAT NIGHT AFTER SUPPER MR. TEFFT SPREAD A NEWSPAPER on the kitchen table. There were seventy-two pieces in the chest, a service for twelve in the Chantilly pattern, given in 1929 by Eleanor's people. He took out the fork with the white spot on its handle and did the whole of it with the pink paste and a soft rag, down between the tines. He rinsed it and dried it and laid it back in its slot among the black ones. Then he turned off the light.

He did one the next night, and one the night after that.

A few days before Thanksgiving he had been once around the chest. He lifted out the first fork to look at it, and there was a yellow cast com-

ing in the bowl of the tines. He was not surprised. He set it on the newspaper and reached for the rag.

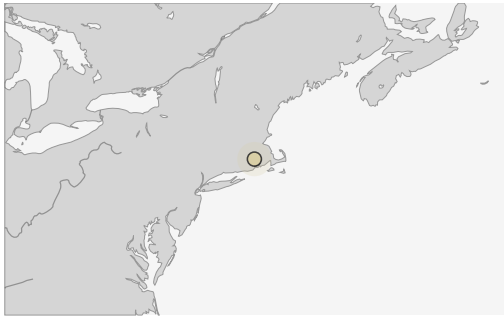
By then it was full dark at five. He stood at the window in his bathrobe with the night's piece drying on a dish towel behind him. The green wagon stopped under the streetlight. Seven bundles went onto the lower bench one after another, and the wagon pulled away. Then the boys came in on their bicycles out of four streets, and dropped the bicycles on the sand, and stood at the two benches under the roof with their elbows at the right height, folding.

Background

The verse

> *Let a wise man blow off the impurities of his self, as a smith blows off the impurities of silver one by one, little by little, and from time to time.*
>
> Dhammapada 239, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary a brahmin of Sāvatthī stands each morning at the place outside the city where the bhikkhus put on their robes before going in for alms. He sees a robe drag through dewy grass, and the next day clears the grass with a mattock. He sees a robe trail in the dust, and spreads sand. On a hot morning he sees them sweat, and puts up a pavilion; on a wet one he sees their robes rained on, and builds a hall. At the feast for its completion he takes the Buddha's bowl and tells him the whole thing from the beginning, and the Buddha answers that a wise man removes his own stains just so, little by little and moment by moment, as a smith does with silver. Read the full commentary story.



Cranston, Rhode Island

Cranston, *1966*

Cranston lies just south and west of Providence, and by the 1960s much of it was streets of postwar houses. The morning *Providence Journal* and its afternoon sister, the *Evening Bulletin*, were carried house to house by boys, as papers were all over the country: a district man dropped wired bundles at a corner before dawn, and the carriers folded them, bagged them and rode their routes before school. Mr. Tefft's trade was mechanical drawing by hand, and a checker was the senior draftsman who went over every sheet before it left the room. His employer, the machine-tool and measuring-instrument maker Brown & Sharpe, left its old Providence works for North Kingstown in 1964. Larkspur Road, Wheelock Avenue and the people on them are invented. Coffee milk is what Rhode Island children drink.

The Gorham Manufacturing Company made silver in Providence from 1831, and from 1890 in a great works in the Elmwood neighborhood, not far from Cranston. Its Chantilly flatware pattern dates from 1895. Women there worked in the case room, among other departments, sewing the linings of presentation cases and the flannel bags that kept silver from the air. The evangelist Billy Sunday held some seventy meetings in a wooden tabernacle in Providence in September and October 1918, until the city closed public gatherings on account of the influenza. "Brighten the Corner Where You Are," with words by Ina Duley Ogdon and music by Charles H. Gabriel, was published in 1913 and became the theme song of his campaigns under his song leader Homer Rodeheaver.

After the story of a certain brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 239). The original. Verse from the hymn "Brighten the Corner Where You Are" by Ina Duley Ogdon (1913). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

18.3

Seven Days on the Nail

> *Your gold and your silver have become covered with rust, and the rust on them will give evidence against you, and will eat your flesh like fire.*
> *— James 5:3 (Weymouth)*

Näin minä sen kuulin, in the East End of Negaunee.

I. The Sarka

Negaunee and Ishpeming, Michigan · spring 1928

Toivo Rautio's mother sent him eight yards of sarka from Ostrobothnia, folded in brown paper and tied with string and smelling, when he opened it on his bunk, of the shed where she kept the loom. It was the coarse gray homespun that farmers wore in the old country to the fields and to church and to their graves. It was as stiff as a horse blanket. He was twenty-three and had been four years in Michigan, tramming ore cars underground on the night shift, and he had not had a new coat since the one he came over in.

On Sunday he took it over to his sister in Ishpeming, three miles west.

Hilja was married to a timberman and had two children and a loom that took up half the front room, a big four-post loom that her husband had built her out of maple, on which she wove rag rugs for the company store at a dollar and a quarter apiece. She unfolded the sarka on the kitchen table and rubbed it between her fingers and looked at her brother, who was the youngest of seven and the only one of them besides herself who had come over, and she thought: this is not good enough for him.

She did not say so. She said, *Leave it with me a while.*

When he had gone back to Negaunee she took the shears to it. She cut the sarka into strips the way she cut old shirts for rugs, and soaked the strips in a tub, and beat them on the back step with a wooden paddle until the weave gave up and the wool came loose, and picked the strips apart thread by thread at the kitchen table in the evenings after the children were asleep. She washed the wool twice and carded it on her mother's cards, which she had brought over in her trunk, and spun it on the wheel, finer than her mother had spun it, as fine as she could make it go without breaking, until her fingertips were raw. Then she put it on the loom and wove it, a close, soft twill, dark gray with a thread of black, and because she had spun it so fine there was more of it than there had been. It came off the loom nine yards long.

It took her until the end of July. She kept back the last of the yarn on a bobbin in her sewing box.

• • •

Toivo came for his cloth at the beginning of August with two men from his boarding house, old Kalle Niemi and Jussi Pelto, who had been tailors in Vaasa before the mines and still sewed in the evenings for the other boarders at fifty cents an evening, and who had brought their shears and their chalk and their thread in a cigar box.

Hilja took the cloth down from the shelf and put it in his hands. He unfolded it on the table, and the tailors leaned over it, and Kalle whistled.

This isn't mine, Toivo said. *Mine was sarka. Eight yards, coarse. This is fine cloth, this is nine yards at least. This is yours. Give me mine.*

It's yours. Take it.

I don't want what's yours. Give me what I brought.

She held it out to him again and he put his hands behind his back like a boy. So she told him. She told him about the shears and the tub and the paddle and the cards and the wheel and her fingertips, and showed him her fingertips, and put the cloth in his hands a third time.

This one is yours, she said. *Take it.*

He took it.

II. The Coat

Mrs. Lehto's boarding house, the East End · August

Mrs. Lehto kept fourteen men in a long frame house on the East End of Negaunee, two to a room and some of them three, the day shift sleeping in the beds the night shift had just got out of. There was a sauna in the yard that she heated on Saturdays, with an iron kettle built into the stove for the wash water. The Finns called a house like hers a *poikatalo,* a boys' house, though some of the boys were fifty.

The tailors cut the coat on her kitchen table, after supper, with the oilcloth rolled back. They made it the way coats were made for Sunday in Vaasa, long, with a high notch and three buttons, and they argued about the shoulders for two nights. Hilja came over from Ishpeming every evening that week, her husband driving her in the Ford when he was on days. She brought coffee and a braid of pulla with cardamom in it, and once a pan of rice pudding, and she fed the tailors and the boarders who sat around the kitchen watching, and on the last night, when the coat was done, she brought a whole cake with lingonberries on it and set out a dollar each for Kalle and Jussi on top of what Toivo owed them.

Toivo put the coat on. The men stood back. He went to the piece of mirror over the washstand and looked at himself, and turned, and looked again, and ran his hand down the front of it, and could not stop. It was the finest thing he had ever had on his back. He looked, Jussi said, like a schoolmaster. He looked, Kalle said, like a man who owned a mine.

Tomorrow, he said, *I'll wear it to the dance at the hall.*

He took it off and brushed it with his hand and hung it on the nail at the head of his bunk, where he could see it from his pillow.

He had eaten three pieces of the cake, and salt herring before that at supper, and some time after midnight the pain came in his belly, low on the right side. He did not wake anybody. The man in the other bunk was on the night shift. He lay on his side and looked at the coat on the nail in the light from the street, and drew his knees up, and in the morning when the night shift came in he was dead.

III. The Seam

The East End · the end of August

THEY BURIED HIM FROM THE FINNISH CHURCH WITH THE boarders for pallbearers, and when it was over and the boarders had come back to the house Hilja came with them and went down on her knees on Mrs. Lehto's kitchen floor, among the boots, and held on to Kalle Niemi's ankles and wept, and rolled her head against the floor, and could not be got up for a long time. Mrs. Lehto put a pillow under her. The men stood around with their caps in their hands and looked at the stove.

Afterward, when Hilja's husband had taken her home, the boarders sat around the table with the coffee, and the question of the coat came up, because it was hanging on the nail in the next room and every one of them had been thinking about it.

There was a custom in the boarding houses about a dead man's clothes. If somebody had sat up with him at the end, the clothes were his. If nobody had, they belonged to the house, and the men drew lots. Nobody had sat up with Toivo. Hilja had said, on the way to the cemetery, that the boys should have it; he would want it worn. So the coat was the house's. Only first, because it was the custom also, it would go in the sauna kettle on Saturday and be boiled, as every dead man's clothes were, for the lice.

Boil that? said Kalle. *You'll ruin it. You'll shrink it to fit a dog.*

Then you can have it. You're the size of a dog.

They laughed for the first time that day, and it was then, the way they all told it afterward, that the voice came out of the next room.

It was the smallest voice any of them had ever heard. It was thinner than a mosquito. It was in Finnish, in Toivo's Ostrobothnian, and what it said was *Thieves! Thieves! That's mine, you're robbing me, that's mine,* over and over, and the boarders looked at each other across the table and nobody moved.

Old Matti Hautala got up. He had been sitting by the stove, where he always sat. He went into the next room and stood in front of the coat on

its nail and looked at it for a long time, close, the way he had once looked at iron in the fire to see what color it had come to. Then he came back.

Nobody touches that coat, he said. *It stays on the nail seven days. Nobody boils it, nobody tries it on, nobody draws for it. Seven days.*

Matti was seventy-one. He had been a blacksmith at the Jackson mine for thirty-one years, sharpening drill steel, until his eyes went, and he had been a red since the strike of 1913 and did not go to church, and he kept the sauna for Mrs. Lehto in exchange for his board. He did not talk much. When he did, the men did what he said, the Lutherans and the reds both, and nobody could have told you why.

Some of them said afterward that they had seen it, that if you went close to the coat on the nail you could see a louse running up and down along the inside of the seam of the left sleeve, this way and that way, and hear it. Others said they never saw a thing. Jussi Pelto, who had made the sleeve, said to the end of his life that he did not know what he had seen, and did not want to talk about it.

IV. The Moving

From the East End to Pine Street · the first week of September

The ground under the East End had been mined for eighty years, and it was going. There were cracks in the backyards you could put your arm in. The Cleveland-Cliffs Iron Company had bought the houses one after another all summer, and in August it asked the city to close the streets, and now the houses were going, the ones that could be moved, up the hill to new lots on the north side of town. Two of the Lutheran churches were going, one of them parsonage and all. Mrs. Lehto had sold to the company in July, and the movers had her house on the list for the first week in September.

So the seven days were the days of the moving, and the boarders packed. They packed the beds and the stove and the washstand and the piece of mirror and Mrs. Lehto's dishes in barrels of straw, and the coat hung on its nail.

The movers came on the fourth day with timbers and jacks and a team of horses and a capstan, and they jacked the house up off its stone foundation and set it on cribbing and then on rollers, and it went up the hill a few yards an hour, creaking, with the horses walking round and round the capstan and the cable singing, and men running from the back of the house to the front with the rollers. Matti walked beside it the whole way. When it tipped going over the curb at Case Street the boarders could hear things fall inside, and Matti went in by the back door, which was a step up to his waist now, and came out again and said the coat was still on its nail. It swung. That was all.

Behind them, where the house had been, there was a hole full of old stones and broken crockery and a rhubarb plant, and the ground all around was the color of rust. On the East End all the dirt was that color. It came up out of the ground on everything, on the boots and the wash and the dogs and the children. You could not keep a white shirt white.

They set the house down on its new foundation on Pine Street on the evening of the seventh day.

V. The Spike

Pine Street · the eighth day

In the morning Matti went in and took the coat down off the nail and brought it out to the kitchen and laid it across the table.

Now, he said. *Boil it, draw for it, do what you want.*

They boiled it. It came out of the kettle a little smaller and none the worse, and they hung it to dry on the line in the new yard, and that evening they drew for it with burnt matches, and Arvo Salo, who was seventeen and had been in the country since June, drew the short one, and put it on, and it fit him.

Then they asked Matti. They sat around Mrs. Lehto's table in the new kitchen, which was the same kitchen a quarter mile north and slightly crooked, so that the coffee in the cups did not sit level, and they asked him why seven days, and why the eighth.

Matti looked at his hands.

Toivo was in the coat, he said. *You heard him. He went to sleep looking at it and he woke up in the seam. If you had boiled it the first day, he'd have gone out of the world cursing every one of you for a thief, and a man who goes out cursing goes down. So I let him run out his time. He's gone up now. Now you can have it.*

Nobody laughed. Arvo, who was wearing it, sat very still.

Matti got up and went out the back door and came back with something from the yard, where the movers had left a pile of rubbish: an old railroad spike, bent, crusted over with rust so thick it had swollen the iron and split it. He put it on the oilcloth among the cups.

You know where rust comes from? he said. *Not from the rain. The rain only helps. It comes out of the iron. Nobody puts it on. It comes up out of the iron and eats the iron, until there's no iron left, only the rust.* He pushed the spike a little with one finger. *Look at this town. They dug it out of the ground and the ground eats it. Look at that boy, God rest him. A coat, his sister's coat. It came out of him, the wanting, and it ate him.*

Then he said it the way he had learned it at confirmation school in Lapua sixty years before, from a pastor he hated, and had never forgotten, because it was the one place in the Bible the reds all knew by heart.

> *Come, you rich men, weep aloud and howl for your sorrows which will soon be upon you. Your treasures have rotted, and your piles of clothing are moth-eaten; your gold and your silver have become covered with rust, and the rust on them will give evidence against you, and will eat your flesh like fire.*
>
> *— James 5:1–3 (Weymouth)*

He wasn't rich, said Arvo.

No, said Matti. *He had one coat.*

• • •

Arvo wore it to the dance at the hall that Saturday, and to church, and to his wedding in 1934, and was buried in Hilja's cloth in 1971, though by then it had been turned twice and was not the same coat. Hilja saw him in it, the first Sunday, across the church. She went over after the service

and took the cuff of the left sleeve between her finger and thumb, and rubbed it, and felt the twill she had made, and let it go.

The spike stayed on the windowsill of Mrs. Lehto's kitchen on Pine Street as long as she lived, and dropped a little ring of red on the white paint, which she scrubbed every spring and which every spring came back.

Background

The verse

> *As the impurity which springs from the iron, when it springs from it, destroys it; thus do a transgressor's own works lead him to the evil path.*
>
> Dhammapada 240, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the monk Tissa receives a length of coarse cloth and gives it to his sister, who secretly cuts it up, beats it to fiber, spins it fine and has it woven into finer, longer cloth. He refuses it until she tells him what she has done. Robe-makers sew it while she feeds them, and he folds the finished robe on the rack, meaning to wear it the next day, but dies in the night of indigestion and is reborn as a louse in the robe. When the monks, since no one nursed him, move to divide it, the louse runs up and down screaming that they are plundering his property. The Buddha has the robe set aside for seven days; the louse dies and is reborn in the Tusita heaven, and on the eighth day the monks divide it. Had they taken it while he still clung to it, the Buddha explains, he would have died hating them and gone to hell; craving eats the one it arises in, as rust eats the iron it comes from. Read the full commentary story, or about taṇhā, craving.

Negaunee, Michigan

The Marquette Iron Range, 1928

Iron ore was found near Negaunee in 1844, and the Jackson Mine there opened the Lake Superior iron country. By the 1920s the ground under the old town had been worked for generations, and roughly half of Negaunee was eventually abandoned for fear of cave-ins. In August 1928, the Mining Journal reported that the Cleveland-Cliffs Iron Company had bought most of the homes in the East End and was offering settlements; the city was asked to vacate and close several of its streets, and houses and churches, among them Immanuel and Bethany Lutheran, were moved north to new lots. Two years earlier, in November 1926, the Barnes-Hecker mine four miles west of Ishpeming had caved in and flooded, killing 51 men.

Finns came to the Upper Peninsula by the tens of thousands from the 1870s on, and many of the single men lived in boarding houses with a sauna in the yard. The Finns were divided between church people and "reds," socialists and union men; the Finnish socialist paper *Työmies*, which had broken with its Lutheran backers, played a major role in the Copper Country strike of 1913–14 in the Keweenaw, to the north. Sarka is the coarse woolen homespun of the Finnish countryside. The verse comes from Richard Francis Weymouth's *New Testament in Modern Speech*, first published in 1903.

After the story of the Elder Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 240). The original. Scripture from Richard Francis Weymouth, *The New Testament in Modern Speech* (third edition, 1913). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.4

Rocks and Shoals

Or, sleeps upon his watch;
— Articles for the Government of the Navy (1930), Article 4

Now this is no shit, in the after battery of a Portsmouth boat.

I. School of the Boat

On patrol, west of the Marianas · June 1944

THERE WERE NINETEEN MEN ABOARD WHO HAD NOT QUALIFIED, and every night after the evening meal, when the tables in the crew's mess had been wiped down and the coffee made again, one of the two chiefs would sit at the end of the forward table and teach them the boat.

Chief Fessenden, the chief of the boat, took the hull systems: trim and drain, high-pressure air, the vents and the floods, the ballast and the negative tank. He drew them on the back of a mess tray with a grease pencil, wiped it with his sleeve, and drew them again, faster. Chief Mullan, the senior electrician, took the batteries and the motors and everything with a wire in it, and he did it without drawing at all, with his eyes shut, walking them through the boat in their minds from the forward torpedo room to the after one, valve by valve, so that a nineteen-year-old from Akron who had never seen the sea before March could close his eyes in his bunk afterward and go aft in the dark and put his hand on the right wheel. Nobody slept through either of them. The nonquals carried their qualification notebooks around the boat like missals. When they went up to the conning tower or back to the maneuvering room to get a signature for something they had learned, the qualified men would ask them who taught them that, and they would say Fessenden, or they would say Moon Mullan, and the qualified men would sign.

Wendell Corliss heard this for three weeks and could not stand it any longer.

He was a torpedoman second class from Clay Hill, New Hampshire, and he had been a rigger at the Portsmouth Navy Yard before the war and had watched this very boat's hull go together on the ways, and he had worn his dolphins for two patrols. He was a big, loud, friendly man who took up the whole passageway. He had qualified in eleven months, which was fast, by learning everything at once the week before his board, the way he had learned the Grange ritual at fifteen, and he had not looked at any of it since.

You think that's teaching, he said one night, in the after battery, to a table of nonquals playing acey-deucy. *Fessenden draws you a picture. You ought to hear me go through trim and drain sometime. You'd never go back.*

The nonquals looked at each other. They had not known. They thought: here is a third one, and we have been passing him in the passageway for a month. The next afternoon, very politely, a fireman named Szabo came to him with three others behind him and asked whether, after the evening meal, if he wasn't on watch, the torpedoman would give them school of the boat.

Corliss said he'd be glad to.

II. Four Times

The crew's mess · the same night, and the next morning

THEY HAD CHICKEN THAT NIGHT OUT OF A CAN, AND JELL-O, and the cooks put out a fresh pot of coffee for the occasion. More men came than usually came for Fessenden, because word had gone around. They sat on the benches and stood in the doorway to the galley, and somebody gave Corliss the seat at the end of the forward table and a clean tray and the grease pencil.

It was over ninety degrees in the mess, as it always was after a day submerged, and Corliss had brought his fan. He had won it at the rest camp at the Royal Hawaiian, a palm-leaf fan painted with a hula girl and a sun-

set, and he fanned himself with it now, slowly, back and forth, and looked at the clean tray.

He had learned the trim system once, all of it, in the week before his board. He remembered that there was a trim pump. He remembered that there was a manifold. He remembered the feeling of knowing it, which was a good feeling, and he could not find anything else.

He fanned himself. The men waited.

Tell you what, he said. *I'll draw it. Szabo, you talk it. You learn better saying it yourself.* And he got up from the seat and handed Szabo the pencil, and Szabo, who had had it from Fessenden two nights before, stood at the end of the table and talked it, haltingly, while Corliss leaned in the galley door and nodded as if he were checking him.

When Szabo was done, they gave Corliss the seat again, to draw it.

He sat down and picked up the pencil and looked at the tray and fanned himself. Then he said he had the midwatch and needed his rack, but that on the midwatch, when it was quiet, he'd go over the whole hydraulic system with anybody who wanted it, which was better anyway, the hydraulics. Somebody else could draw tonight. And he got up again.

Four men came to the after torpedo room at midnight. He sat on the skid between the reload torpedoes with his fan and looked at them. He said it was too hot back there to think straight, and he'd do it at morning twilight, after they dove, when it was cool and everybody was fresh, and he went on watch.

At morning twilight they dove. The boat went down to a hundred feet and settled, and the nonquals came to the crew's mess with their notebooks, and so did a good many of the others, because by now everybody had heard. Corliss sat down a fourth time at the end of the table and picked up the fan, and there was a long silence in which the only sound was the ventilation, and somebody's notebook falling off a bench, and then Moon Mullan's voice from the galley door, mild, saying, *Go on, Corliss. Start at the sea chest.*

Corliss fanned himself.

The first potato came from the back, from behind the coffee urn. It hit the bulkhead over his head. The second one hit him in the chest. Then

the cooks' whole morning bucket of peeled potatoes was going, and the bread rolls from the night before, and an aluminum mug, and somebody had a broom. *You said you could teach it better than the Chief,* they said. *You sat there four times. Say something now.* They were laughing, but they were not altogether laughing. They had given up their sleep for him.

Corliss went out through the after door with his fan over his head.

III. The After Head

The after battery compartment

He went aft fast, through the crew's berthing, with twenty men behind him and potatoes knocking on the lockers, and he ducked into the after head and dogged the door, and sat down hard, and, because he had been holding it since the midwatch and because it was the first thing in two days that he did not have to explain, he finished his business and reached for the valve.

There was a sign hung on the valve. The motor machinist had hung it there twenty minutes earlier, when he started blowing the sanitary tank overboard with high-pressure air, the way it was done every couple of days. Corliss had helped write the sign. He knew the order of the valves on that head as well as he knew anything aboard; he had known it once. He did not read it.

The sound it made was heard as far forward as the control room.

When he came out, a while afterward, he had the hula fan in his hand still, and the men in the passageway parted and pressed themselves back against the bunks to let him by, all of them, without a word, the way water parts around a hull. He went forward to the washroom. He was in there a long time. The smell went through the whole after battery and the ventilation took it into the crew's mess and laid it on the tables like a cloth, and nobody could eat breakfast, and nobody, after that, threw anything.

IV. The Lion and the Pig

The crew's mess · that afternoon

THE OFFICERS' STEWARD WAS A CHAMORRO FROM HAGÅTÑA named Vicente Taitano. He was forty-one. He had been in the Navy since 1923, as a mess attendant and then a steward, because that was what the Navy had let a man from Guam be, and he had a wife and three daughters on Guam whom he had not heard from since the Japanese came ashore in December of 1941. He made the coffee in the wardroom and ironed the captain's khakis and kept the wardroom silver, which nobody used, as bright as if somebody would. He spoke English carefully and not much. The captain sometimes asked him things that had nothing to do with coffee.

He came through the crew's mess in the middle of the afternoon with a tray of cups to wash and found a dozen men around the forward table going over the whole thing again. He set the tray down.

What are you all talking about?

They told him: Corliss, the seat, the four times, the potatoes, the head. They were laughing again by then. Corliss was in his rack with the curtain drawn.

Taitano nodded. *That's not the first time for him,* he said.

He sat down on the end of the bench and dried his hands on the towel over his shoulder, and told them a story the friars told in the school at Hagåtña when he was a boy, which he said they had brought from Spain, and which he thought they had got from somewhere further off.

There was a lion who lived in the mountains above a lake, he said. On the shore of the lake lived a lot of wild pigs, and at the other end lived some friars in huts. One day the lion came down to drink, and a big pig was rooting at the edge of the water. The lion thought, I'll eat him another day, and so as not to scare him off, he went quietly away up the bank. The pig saw that. He thought, the lion is afraid of me. He called after him. You have four feet, friend, and I have four feet. Come back. What are you running for?

The lion said, Not today, friend pig. A week from today, here. And went home.

The pig was so happy he ran and told all the other pigs. They were terrified. *You don't know what you are,* they told him. *He'll kill you and the rest of us too.* Then the pig was afraid. *What do I do?* And the old pigs said: Go roll in the friars' dung heap. Every day for seven days. Let it dry on you. The seventh day, wet yourself with the dew, get there first, and stand upwind. The lion is a clean animal. He won't touch you.

So that's what the pig did. On the seventh day the lion came down and smelled him from a long way off. *Friend pig,* the lion said, *that's a good trick. If you were clean I'd kill you today. As it is I can't bite you. I can't put my foot on you. You want to fight? You win. I give it to you.* And the lion went and drank somewhere else.

The pig went home and told everybody he had beaten the lion. And the other pigs were so scared the lion would come back that they packed up and moved to the other side of the island.

The men in the mess were quiet a minute. Then one of the nonquals said, *So the Chief's the lion.*

Taitano picked up his tray. *That's right.*

And Corliss is the pig.

Same pig, said Taitano, *as always.* He looked down the passageway toward the after battery, where the curtain on Corliss's rack had not moved. *He learned a little of it one time, for his dolphins. Then he never said it again. A thing you don't say over goes bad on you. Like a house nobody fixes. You leave a house on Guam one rainy season with nobody in it, it's gone.*

He took the cups to the galley sink.

V. Muster

The first of July, and after

On the first of the month the executive officer read the Articles for the Government of the Navy to the ship's company in the crew's mess, in two sittings so the watch could hear them, as the Articles themselves required, once a month. Everybody called them Rocks and

Shoals. Most of the men could have said the long part by heart, and some of them said it along with him under their breath, the way you say a prayer you have heard a hundred times in church. Corliss stood against the bulkhead at the back with his arms folded. He had been given the after head to keep for the rest of the patrol, and it was the cleanest place on the boat.

> *The punishment of death, or such other punishment as a court martial may adjudge, may be inflicted on any person in the naval service —*
>
> *Or, sleeps upon his watch;*
>
> *Or leaves his station before being regularly relieved;*
>
> *— Articles for the Government of the Navy (1930), Article 4*

Afterward the nonquals went back to Fessenden and Moon Mullan in the evenings, and they qualified, most of them, before the end of the year. But something else happened, which the chiefs noticed. Men who had been qualified for years began coming to school of the boat. They sat at the back with their coffee and said nothing, and when Fessenden drew the trim system, some of them moved their lips. A motor machinist who had worn his dolphins since 1938 asked Mullan, privately, to walk him through the after battery again from the beginning. Mullan did, with his eyes shut.

Corliss stood the four-to-eight lookout watch on the after periscope shears for the rest of the patrol. The officer of the deck heard him at morning twilight, with the binoculars up, sweeping his sector in the gray, saying something to himself, low and steady, over and over. It took the officer of the deck a while to make out what it was. It was the valve line-up for the trim manifold, from the sea chest aft, in order. When he got to the end he began it again.

On the twenty-first of July the radioman brought a message to the wardroom saying the Marines and the Army were ashore on Guam. The captain read it, and handed it to Taitano, who was pouring his coffee, and Taitano read it standing up with the pot in his hand. Then he set the pot down and went to his pantry and took out the wardroom silver, all of it,

the forks and the spoons and the coffee service nobody had ever used, and spread a towel on the counter, and began to polish it, one piece and then the next, though it was already bright.

• • •

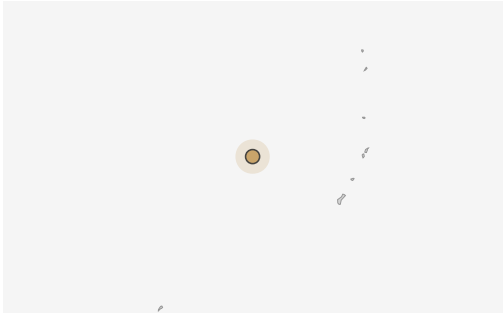
Wendell Corliss went home to Clay Hill in the fall of 1945, to his wife and a seven-year-old son named Lyle who did not know him. He took the hula fan with him. It hung for years on a nail in the Grange hall kitchen, where the women used it at suppers in August, and nobody but Wendell knew what it had been through, and he never told it on himself. Other men did.

Background

The verse

> *The taint of prayers is non-repetition; the taint of houses, non-repair; the taint of the body is sloth; the taint of a watchman, thoughtlessness.*
>
> Dhammapada 241, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the lay disciples of Sāvatthī go home from the monastery praising the elders Sāriputta and Moggallāna, and the monk Lāḷudāyi, jealous, tells them they should hear him. They invite him to teach. He sits in the preacher's seat waving a painted fan and cannot find a word; he says he will chant instead and let someone else teach, then that he will chant at night, then at dawn. Four times they seat him, and four times he gets down. At last the crowd picks up clods and sticks, and he runs and falls into a cesspool. The Buddha says it is not the first time, and tells the birth story of a boar who challenged a lion, rolled for seven days in the ascetics' dung heap, and was told by the disgusted lion, "I give you the victory." Lāḷudāyi, the Buddha says, learned a fragment of the teaching and never repeated it. Read the full commentary story and the birth story of the boar.



A fleet submarine on patrol west of the Marianas

A fleet boat off the Marianas, 1944

The Balao-class fleet submarines, built at the Portsmouth Navy Yard in Kittery, Maine, and at other yards, carried about ten officers and seventy enlisted men and could go to four hundred feet. Every enlisted man had to qualify in submarines, learning each system of the boat well enough to operate it and explain it, before he could wear the dolphins. Waste from the heads went to sanitary tanks that were blown overboard with compressed air; a man who opened the wrong valve while a tank was under pressure got it back. Between patrols, crews rested at Waikiki's Royal Hawaiian Hotel, which the military used as a rest and recreation center for the whole war. The Articles for the Government of the Navy, known as Rocks and Shoals, were by their own terms to be hung up in a public part of every ship and read to the ship's company once a month.

Japan seized Guam on December 10, 1941, days after Pearl Harbor, and held it for two and a half years, eventually moving most of the Chamorro population into camps such as Manenggon. Twelve Chamorro men serving as Navy mess attendants had died aboard the battleships at Pearl Harbor; others served through the war without word from home. After weeks of bombardment, American forces landed on July 21, 1944, still kept on Guam as Liberation Day; see also Guampedia on the Chamorro mess attendants of 1941.

After the story of the elder Lāḷudāyi from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 241). The original. Quotations from the Articles for the Government of the Navy (1930). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.5

The Backstaff

From ignorance comes vice, from error heresy, &c.
— Robert Burton, The Anatomy of Melancholy

As I had it told me, on the beach at Nassau.

I. The School

Nassau, New Providence · spring 1719

Mr. Prys kept his school of navigation in a palmetto house at the east end of the town, below the ridge, where the ground was too stony for anyone to want it. He had been a sea artist forty years. He was Welsh, from Carmarthen, and very old, and he had sailed as master's mate and master out of Bristol and Kingston and Boston, and in the year 1697 a pirate had taken his ship off Hispaniola and kept him eight months because a pirate who cannot find the way home is only a man in a boat. He did not talk about those months. He had come to New Providence afterward, by what road nobody knew, and stayed.

When the Governor came in the summer of 1718 with his men-of-war and the King's pardon, there were two hundred and more men on the island who had been on the account, and most of them took it, and then sat about the town with nothing to do. Some of them had money and drank it. Some went turtling, or raked salt, or went out to the wrecks on the banks. A few of them, the ones who could add, came to the palmetto house in the evenings and paid Mr. Prys a piece of eight a month to learn what he knew, because a man who could keep a reckoning could get a mate's berth on any honest sloop in the Indies, and a man who could not would be raking salt at forty.

He taught them with a slate and a box of sand and a traverse board with its pegs on strings, and a brass-bound backstaff that had been to Guinea and back. He made them say everything aloud. Plane sailing, middle-latitude sailing, the log and the half-minute glass, how to work a day's work from the pegs. The sun's declination for every day of the year, which he had by heart and made them have. The backstaff, he told them, was the cleverest thing an Englishman ever made, because you used it with your back to the sun. You did not look at the thing you were measuring. You looked at its shadow on the vane, and at the horizon, and the truth was where the two met.

Nathaniel Cole was the best of them that spring. He was twenty-three, the younger son of a Bristol sugar baker, and he had run away to sea at fifteen and been taken out of a Jamaica sloop in 1716 and signed the articles of the men who took him, and stayed with them two years, and done what they did. He took the pardon on the second day. He had come out of it with a share he never spoke of. He was quick with figures and slow with everything else, and he listened to the old man the way a dog listens at a door.

In April he married Susannah Thompson, whose people had been on the island since before anyone could remember and kept a few goats and a fig tree up the hill behind the town. She was nineteen. She had a laugh you could hear from the waterfront. They were married in her mother's house, before witnesses, and Mr. Prys came and stood at the back in his old blue coat and drank one glass and went home.

II. The Town

The waterfront · summer 1719

NASSAU IN THAT YEAR WAS A FEW HUNDRED MEN AND NOT many women. There was a fort going up on the point that nobody wanted to work at, so the Governor had declared martial law to make them, and there was fever among the people he had brought, who died of it while the old islanders went on as if it were weather. There were taverns made of ship's planks and sailcloth all along the beach. There was always a

fiddle somewhere. The gallows from the December hanging had been taken down, but people still pointed at the place.

Nat Cole went to the Exumas raking salt in May, and to the banks after turtle in June, and was gone three weeks each time. Before the month was out the whole waterfront knew that his wife had not been sitting in the dark while he was away. She had been at the dancing at the sign of the Ship, and at the other places, and she had not always gone home alone. It was the kind of town where everyone knew everything by morning, and said so.

He heard it the day he landed, from three men, before his feet were dry. He went home and sat in the doorway and looked at her. She looked back at him. She did not deny it.

She did not explain it either, though there were things she could have said. That he had brought home from the account a share of Spanish silver that she had never seen, because he kept it in a jar under the floor of their house and would not spend a real of it, and she had been married four months in the same two shifts she was married in. That he was gone more than he was home, and when he was home he sat with his slate doing sums. That she was nineteen, and the fiddles were playing every night on the beach of the only town she had ever lived in, and the men there spent their money as if it were sand. She said none of that. She went out to her mother's.

Nat stopped going out. He stopped going down to the waterfront, where men nodded at him in a way he could feel between his shoulders. He did not go back to the salt sloop. He did not go to Mr. Prys's school in the evenings. He sat in the house with the door shut in the heat and did sums on his slate that came out to nothing, and he took the jar up from under the floor and counted it, and put it back.

III. The Backstaff

The school below the ridge · August 1719

After eleven days it came round to the first of the month, and the first of the month was when he paid the old man his

PIECE OF EIGHT. HE COULD NOT BRING HIMSELF NOT TO PAY A debt. He went up after dark, by the back way along the ridge so nobody would see him, and put the coin on the table, and sat down on the bench in his old place without looking at anybody. There were four other men there, working a traverse.

Mr. Prys finished showing them, and sent them home early. Then he sat down across the table, with the lamp between them.

Mr. Cole. Where have you been? You have not let yourself be seen.

Nat told him all of it, staring at the sand box. The salt, the turtles, the Ship. The three men on the beach. His wife in the doorway, not denying it.

The old man listened. Then he said, *I said all this once before, to a young man of mine. In Port Royal, in Jamaica, before the town went into the sea. His wife was the same, and he came to me the same, and sat where you are sitting. He had your way of sitting. His name was Cole as well.*

Nat looked up. His father had been in Jamaica as a young man; it was where the money came from that bought the sugar house in Bristol. His father had never talked about it, and his mother had never talked about his father.

Mr. Prys did not say anything more about that. He said, *Shall I tell you what I told him?*

Nat said yes.

I told him that a woman is not a cargo you have bought and stowed and can put your mark on. She is like the river, I said, that everyone draws from. Like the King's highway, that everyone walks on. Like the tavern, and the meeting house, and the well in the square. Everyone comes to them. A man may be sorry for it. But a wise man does not stand on the bank and rage at a river. It has nothing to do with him.

Nat said nothing for a long time. Then he said, *What did he do?*

He let it go, after a while. He was easy after that. And the wife heard that I knew what she was, and she left it off. That's all.

The old man reached up to the shelf over the table, where he kept his ephemerides and his Norwood and his Seller, and took down the only other book he had, a fat old folio that had been wet more than once and

dried in the sun so that the boards were warped like a hull. He opened it in the last third without looking for the place, the way a man takes down a tool from the same nail he has always hung it on, and he read aloud.

> *It may be 'tis his own fault, and he hath no reason to complain, 'tis quid pro quo, she is bad, he is worse: Bethink thyself, hast thou not done as much for some of thy neighbours?*
>
> *I do not excuse her in accusing thee; but if both be naught, mend thyself first; for as the old saying is, a good husband makes a good wife.*
>
> *— Robert Burton, The Anatomy of Melancholy, Partition 3, Section 3, Member 4 ("Cure of Jealousy")*

He closed the book on his finger.

How much is in the jar, Mr. Cole?

Nat had not told anybody about the jar. He told the old man the number. It was a good deal.

And what has your wife got on her back?

Nat did not answer that.

Well, said Mr. Prys. *A loose life is a stain on a woman. Nobody here will tell you otherwise, least of all her. And a close fist is a stain on a man who has something to give. Everything wicked we do leaves a mark on us, here and wherever we are going after. But there's a worse one than any of them.* He opened the book again, at the very front, in the long address to the reader, and turned the leaves until he found it.

> *Some say there be two main defects of wit, error and ignorance, to which all others are reduced; by ignorance we know not things necessary, by error we know them falsely. Ignorance is a privation, error a positive act. From ignorance comes vice, from error heresy, &c.*
>
> *— Robert Burton, The Anatomy of Melancholy, "Democritus Junior to the Reader"*

Not knowing, the old man said. *Not knowing what you are doing while you do it. That is the stain under all the others. Get that one off you and the rest come off with it.*

He put the book back on the shelf, and pushed the backstaff across the table.

Here. Show me how you take the sun.

Nat stood up and turned his back on the lamp, as if it were the sun, and raised the staff, and found the shadow of the vane, and the line of the wall where the horizon would be, and the old man watched him do it and said, *Yes. Like that. You don't look at the thing. You stand with your back to it and look at what it throws.*

IV. The Fig Tree

Up the hill · autumn 1719

It was Mrs. Thompson who told her daughter, because Mrs. Thompson's sister did the old man's washing, and nothing on New Providence went unsaid for long. She told her that Nat Cole had sat in Mr. Prys's school until midnight, and that the old Welshman knew all about her, and had read to Nat out of his great book, and that whatever it was, Nat had come down from the ridge looking like a man who had been told something.

Susannah had not cared what the waterfront said. The waterfront said everything about everyone and had since she was a child. But the old man had come to her wedding in his blue coat and drunk his one glass and gone home, and when she was nine and had fever, before anyone on the island had heard of a governor, he had walked up the hill every evening for a week with a lime and a little sugar in a paper and sat by the door saying the names of the stars to her until she slept. She had not known he would know. She had thought of him as somebody whose eyes were always on the sky.

She sat under her mother's fig tree for the rest of that day with her hands in her lap, and the next day she did not go down to the beach, nor the day after.

Nat came up the hill at the end of the week. He had a bolt of blue Holland cloth under his arm and two pairs of shoes off a Boston trader in the

harbor, and he did not say anything about them. He put them on the bench by her mother's door. He had taken them out of the jar.

She went home with him that evening. Neither of them said anything about the summer then or afterward. The waterfront talked a while longer, and found other things to talk about, as it always did. That winter Nat shipped as mate in a Boston sloop in the salt trade, and kept her reckoning so well that her master asked who had taught him, and when he was home Susannah would sit across the table from him while he worked the day's figures and make him say them aloud, the way the old man did, though she did not understand a word of it.

V. The Harbor at Night

Nassau · August 1720

Mr. Prys died in the spring of 1720, after the Spanish came off the harbor in February with a fleet and went away again. He was buried on the ridge above his school, and his men carried him up, eleven of them, all mates and masters now on one coast or another, and Nat Cole took the backstaff, which the old man had said he should have. The folio went to the Governor's secretary, who said he would send it to England, and did not.

On a night in late August, Nat and Susannah were sitting on their step after dark with the door open behind them for the air. There was a little wind off the land. Down in the harbor something was moving without lights: a sloop warping out quietly from the anchorage past the fort, men at her sweeps, no sound but the oars in the water and once a woman's voice laughing, out on the dark, and then a hand put over it.

In the morning the whole waterfront knew that a sloop called the *William* had been stolen out of the harbor by a crowd of men who had taken the King's pardon and were tired of it, and that two of the crowd were women, one of them somebody else's wife, who had gone with them in men's clothes, and the Governor was going to proclaim them all. Everybody on the beach was talking about it, and about her.

Susannah did not talk about it. She had heard the laugh go out over the water, and she had felt Nat beside her on the step hear it too, and not turn his head to look at her. That was all. She got up early and went down to the well in the square with her bucket, where everyone came, and drew her water, and carried it home.

Background

The verses

> *Bad conduct is the taint of woman, greediness the taint of a benefactor; tainted are all evil ways in this world and in the next.*
>
> Dhammapada 242, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But there is a taint worse than all taints,—ignorance is the greatest taint. O mendicants! throw off that taint, and become taintless!*
>
> Dhammapada 243, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a young man of good family marries a woman who is unfaithful from the day of the wedding, and he is so ashamed that he stops showing his face, even to the Buddha. When the Buddha asks where he has been, he tells him everything. The Buddha says he gave the same counsel in a former life, and at the young man's request tells the birth story: a famous teacher whose pupil came to him with the same grief was told that women are like rivers, highways, taverns, assembly halls and wells, open to all, and that the wise are not angry at them. The pupil let it go, and the wife, hearing that the teacher knew what she was, gave up her ways; and so did the wife in the present. Then the Buddha speaks of stains: bad conduct, stinginess, every wicked act, and worst of all, ignorance. Read the full commentary story and the birth story. Mr. Prys reads from Robert Burton's The Anatomy of Melancholy (1621, enlarged through 1676), which has a long section on the cure of jealousy; the text is quoted from the Project Gutenberg edition.

Nassau, New Providence, Bahamas

Nassau, 1718–1720

From about 1713 New Providence was the base of the so-called Republic of Pirates. On July 24, 1718, Woodes Rogers arrived as royal governor with warships and the King's pardon for pirates who surrendered, and most of the two hundred or so former pirates on the island took it. Rogers rebuilt the decayed fort, declaring martial law to make the inhabitants work on it; nearly a hundred of the people he brought died of fever while the old residents were spared. In December 1718 the pardoned pirate Benjamin Hornigold brought in ten men who had gone back to piracy, and eight of them were hanged at Nassau. A Spanish fleet came off the island in February 1720 and withdrew. Navigation in these years was done with the log, the traverse board and the backstaff or Davis quadrant, used with the observer's back to the sun, lining the shadow of a vane up with the horizon.

On the night of August 22, 1720, John Rackham and a few others who had taken the pardon stole the sloop *William* from Nassau harbor; among them were Anne Bonny and Mary Read, whom Rogers named in his proclamation of September 5. The tale that Bonny had left a husband on the island comes from Captain Charles Johnson's *General History of the Pyrates* (1724), a lively and unreliable book. Mr. Prys's young man in Port Royal belongs to the years before the earthquake of June 7, 1692, which sank much of that town into the harbor.

After the story of a certain youth of good family from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 242–243). The original. Quotations from Robert Burton, *The Anatomy of Melancholy*. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.6

Pond Mullet

Though a remedy may be at hand one must not take poison.
— Tannishō XIII, tr. Tosui Imadate (1928)

Kō kiita yo, in Camp Seven.

I. Moxa

West Kauai, Territory of Hawaii · 1908

The temple in Camp Seven stood at the end of the Japanese row, past the bathhouse and the store, on posts high enough that the dogs slept under it. It was board and batten with a tin roof. The plantation had paid for the lumber, the manager having been told in Honolulu that a camp with a temple had fewer fights on payday. Inside, behind a low rail, hung a scroll of Amida Buddha standing on a lotus, and below him two brass vases and a candle stand that the women of the camp polished on Saturdays with ash from the bathhouse fire.

Nishiyama Ryōun had come out from Kyoto in the spring of 1907 to take charge of it. He was twenty-six. He had a good voice for the sutras and a quick laugh, and he could write a letter home for a man in a hand that made the man's mother proud of him. And he had one thing more, which the camp found out in his first month. His father was a village doctor in Aki, in the Hiroshima country, and the son had rolled moxa and ground powders in his father's back room since before he could write his own name.

Most of the camp was from Hiroshima and Yamaguchi, from the old Shin villages where every house had its altar and a man who had never read a book could say whole letters of Rennyo Shōnin by heart. They knew the teaching as well as any priest did on this one point. Followers

of Shinran keep no charms. They buy no prayers for a cure and ask no one for a lucky day. Shinran himself had written that it was a sorrow to see priests and laymen alike counting auspicious days and calling on the gods for help. A Shin priest said the Name, buried the dead, wrote letters, settled quarrels, and left the curing to the doctor.

But the plantation doctor was a haole who rode up from the mill twice a week and spoke no Japanese. It was said he had sent a man back to hāpai kō with two cracked ribs. So people came to the temple instead, at night, by the back steps.

Nishiyama burned moxa on the shoulders of the cane carriers, where the bundles had worn the skin to leather. He gave powders out of the lacquered chest he had brought from his father's house, wrapped in twists of red paper. And when a mother asked him, as they did ask, he wrote the Name on a strip of paper and folded it in three and told her to put it under the pillow. Then he chanted over the child, low, with his eyes closed, words he had been taught were for giving thanks and for the dead and for nothing else.

He was paid in what the camp had. Eggs. A hen with her legs tied. Two bottles of sake from Japan at New Year. Men cut cane in Camp Seven for eighteen dollars a month, and nobody paid a priest in money.

Fujita, who kept the camp store, had a boy of seven who ran a fever for five days in March. On the fifth night Nishiyama burned three cones of moxa on the soles of the boy's feet and wrote the Name for under his pillow, and in the morning the fever had broken. It might have broken anyway. Fujita did not think so. On the following Sunday his wife sent up a three-tiered box of black lacquer, tied in a purple cloth. In the top tier was red rice with black sesame. In the second were pickled ginger and sweet black beans. In the third, laid on a ti leaf, was a whole fat mullet from one of the Hawaiian ponds by the sea, broiled with salt until the skin had blistered gold.

He sat on the temple step and looked at it a long while, and was happy.

He was not a wicked man. He thought, when he thought about it, that the people needed what he gave them and would be worse off without it, and that Amida's Vow had been made for foolish men exactly like him-

self, so where was the harm. Then he did not think about it. He slept well. In the mornings the mynahs woke him.

They had been brought from India forty-odd years before to eat the cutworms out of the young cane. They had eaten the cutworms and then everything else. They walked into the cookhouse when the door was open. They took rice out of a lunch tin while the man it belonged to was still bending over it. They had no fear of anybody, and they shouted all day long about whatever they had. The Hawaiians called them piha'ekelo, full of voice. Every night at dusk they came in from the fields by the hundreds to the monkeypod tree beside the store and quarreled there until dark, and every morning they went out again, and nobody in Camp Seven had ever seen one go hungry.

II. The Ditch Road

That noon

He had a memorial service that afternoon at Camp Nine, across the gulch, and he took the box with him to eat on the way.

The road ran along the top of the ditch bank. On one side was the water, brown and quick, going down to the fields in its plank flume. On the other was cane taller than a man on horseback. At the place where a footbridge crossed the flume, an old woman sat on the planks in the shade of the cane, eating her lunch.

Her name was Higa Ushi. She was from Okinawa, from a village near Nago, and she was the oldest woman in the hoeing gang. The Hiroshima women called her Obaa, grandmother, because they did not know her name. In their worse moods they called the Okinawans in the gang pig-eaters, not always out of her hearing. The backs of her hands were tattooed in dark blue, little crosses and dots and bars, from the knuckles to the wrist, the way the women of her island had been marked for centuries. Her husband had died the second year. She had stayed. She sent money home to a grandson in Nago and kept a hoe whose blade had been filed down to a crescent.

She had a lunch tin on her knees, and in it two boiled sweet potatoes and a pinch of salt.

Nishiyama sat down on the planks beside her and untied the purple cloth.

Obaa-san, look at this. I got this for treating Fujita's boy. Mullet out of a Hawaiian pond. You won't eat like this anywhere on Kauai, I promise you. Take it, eat. He lifted off the top two tiers and held the fish out to her on its leaf. *And from now on, whenever they pay me like this for a treatment, I'll bring you some. Every time.*

She listened to all of it. She looked at the mullet, and then at him, for no longer than it takes to look at anything. Then she put the lid on her tin and stood up, which at her age took a moment. She took up the hoe and went back down into the cane without a word, and the leaves closed behind her.

He sat there holding the fish.

Two women of the gang had been eating at the end of the next row, Mrs. Ōta and Mrs. Hamada, from Yamaguchi. They had seen the whole of it. They looked at him and then at each other and then down into their tins.

He laughed, because there was nothing else to do, and he said something about Okinawan pride, and ate the mullet there on the flume with his fingers. It was very good. Two mynahs came down onto the planks while he ate and walked right up to him, and he threw them the skin, and they fought over it and shouted.

III. The Gate

That night

THE WOMEN TOLD MUKAI JISABURŌ.

They had not decided to. They meant to tell nobody. But Mrs. Ōta saw him that evening outside the store with his lantern and his shovel, going up to the night water, and she found she had stopped him and was telling it, and Mrs. Hamada was nodding beside her.

Jisaburō was sixty-three. He had come out from Aki in 1885, the first year the emigrant ships came, and he had never gone home. He was the night man on the Number Four ditch. All night he walked the lines with a lantern, opening one gate and closing another so that the water went down every furrow in its turn and none of the cane went dry, and at every gate he lifted he said the Name under his breath. He was the head of the temple board because nobody would have it otherwise. Some people in the camp called him a myōkōnin, one of the wondrous good people, behind his back. He would have been ashamed to hear it. He spoke very little.

He listened to the women. He thanked them. Then he set his lantern on the store step and walked down to the temple instead of up to the ditch.

Nishiyama was sitting on the temple step in the dark with the empty lacquer box beside him and a cup of sake. In the monkeypod tree by the store the mynahs were settling, a thousand of them, all shouting.

Jisaburō sat down a step below him. For a while he said nothing.

Listen to them, he said at last.

They make a racket.

An easy life, the mynah's. They came for the cutworms. Now they eat out of everybody's tin. Nobody gives them a thing. They take it, and then they tell the whole valley, and then they sleep well. He was quiet a while. *There's nothing easier than to be a mynah, Sensei.*

Nishiyama poured himself another cup and did not drink it.

Higa-san is in the cane at six, said Jisaburō. *She comes out at half past four. She buys nothing at Fujita's that she can't pay for that day. She has never eaten a mullet like that in her life, and she will not eat yours.* He looked at his own hands. They were split across the knuckles from the shovel. *That is a hard way to live. She gets up every morning and does it again.*

She didn't have to walk off like that.

No.

The mynahs were quieting. A few still shouted, here and there in the tree.

I'm only a ditch man, said Jisaburō. *You've read the books. I never did. I only know what the priest in my village used to say, when I was a boy. In Shinran Shōnin's time there was a man who reasoned that the Vow was made to save evil men, and so he might as well do evil. And when the Shōnin heard about it he wrote a letter.* He said the words carefully, as if lifting a gate board out of its slot.

> *Though a remedy may be at hand one must not take poison.*
>
> *— Tannishō XIII, tr. Tosui Imadate (1928)*

You have the remedy, Sensei. You're the one who taught it to this camp. Every soul in Camp Seven knows it's there. He stood up. *I'm saying it to myself as well. I'm an old fool. I drank away my first three years on this island, and I know how easy the easy life is.*

He bowed, and went back up to the store for his lantern, and Nishiyama watched the light go along the ditch bank into the dark and stop, and stop again, at every gate.

• • •

The next noon at the footbridge Mrs. Ōta came along the bank with her lunch tin and sat down on the planks beside Higa Ushi. She did not say anything about the day before. She opened her tin. She had white rice and a pickled plum and a strip of dried fish, and she set the tin down on the plank between them.

The old woman looked at it. After a while she took one of her two sweet potatoes and broke it in half and laid the larger half in Mrs. Ōta's tin, beside the plum.

Mrs. Ōta asked her where she was from. *Nago,* said Higa Ushi. *Near Nago.* And she said her name.

Two mynahs came down onto the flume and walked up and down the planks in front of them, shouting, and waited, and got nothing.

Background

The verses

> *Life is easy to live for a man who is without shame, a crow hero, a mischief-maker, an insulting, bold, and wretched fellow.*
>
> Dhammapada 244, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But life is hard to live for a modest man, who always looks for what is pure, who is disinterested, quiet, spotless, and intelligent.*
>
> Dhammapada 245, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Culla Sāri, a monk who lived with the elder Sāriputta, gave medical treatment to a lay household and was paid with a portion of choice food. That kind of livelihood was against the rules the Buddha had laid down for monks. On his way back he met an elder on the road and offered him some: nowhere else would he get food like this, and from now on, whenever Culla Sāri was paid like this, he would bring him some. The elder heard him out and walked on without a word. When the monks told the Buddha, he said that a man without shame, bold as a crow, lives easily, and a man with a sense of shame lives hard. Read the full commentary story, or about hiri, the Buddhist sense of shame.

West Kauai, Territory of Hawaii

Kauai, 1908

The first Japanese contract laborers reached Hawaii on February 8, 1885. Most of those who followed came from Hiroshima, Yamaguchi and Kumamoto, to work in the sugar fields. Okinawans began arriving in January 1900, and by 1908 more than 8,500 lived in the islands. Other Japanese looked down on them, called them pig-eaters, and mocked the hajichi tattoos on the women's hands. The Gentlemen's Agreement of 1907–08 ended new emigration of Japanese laborers. When Japanese work-

ers struck on Oahu the next year, their pay was eighteen dollars a month, well below what Portuguese and Puerto Rican workers earned.

Most of the emigrants were Jōdo Shinshū Buddhists. The first Hongwanji temple in the islands was dedicated in 1889, and Bishop Yemyo Imamura led the Honpa Hongwanji Mission from 1900 to 1932. Its ministers traveled the camps on foot and on horseback, held funerals, wrote letters home for the workers, and settled disputes. Some plantations helped pay for the temples. On Kauai the Līhu'e Hongwanji began in 1901 with support from the Lihue Plantation Company. Shin Buddhism rejects charms, spells and prayers for worldly benefit. The words Jisaburō recites come from the Tannishō, a late thirteenth-century record of Shinran's sayings. The common myna was brought to Hawaii from India in the 1860s to eat armyworms and cutworms in the cane, and people complained of it for its noise and its nerve. The Hawaiian name, piha'ekelo, means "full of voice."

After the story of Culla Sāri from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 244–245). The original. Scripture from the Tannishō, translated by Tosui Imadate (1928). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.7

Odd and Even

In my judgment, such of us as have never fallen victims, have been spared more from the absence of appetite, than from any mental or moral superiority over those who have.
— Abraham Lincoln, Address to the Springfield Washingtonian Temperance Society, 1842

Way I heard it, in the back of the Columbia van.

I. The Back Rows

Columbia, Maryland · June 1979

The van left the lot behind the Oakland Mills village center at ten minutes to seven, and it did not wait. Everybody knew that. Bernie Ostrowski had driven it since the winter of the first gas lines, in 1974, a fifteen-passenger Dodge the color of a Concord grape, and in five and a half years he had left behind two of his own supervisors at the General Accounting Office, a woman in a wedding dress on her way to the courthouse, and once, by about forty seconds, his wife. The riders paid him by the month. He kept the van in his driveway on Sohap Lane, washed it on Saturdays, and drove it down Route 29 and Colesville Road and Sixteenth Street every working day, and he almost never said anything, because he was driving.

There were eleven riders that June. Most of them slept or read the *Post*. The five in the back two rows talked, all the way down and all the way back, and over the years each of the five had come to know one thing about the other four, which was the thing each of them did not do.

Walt Haney did not kill anything. He was thirty-three and worked for the Fish and Wildlife Service in the Interior building, where he spent

half the year adding up ducks. Every winter he flew low over the Chesapeake in a small plane with a clipboard and counted canvasbacks on the water. He had been a Marine at Hue in 1968 and had come home and put his father's shotgun in the attic, and since then he had not killed so much as a fish. When a wasp came in the van window he trapped it in a paper cup against the glass and held it there until the next light, and let it out.

Carol Lindgren did not lie. She was an economist at the Bureau of Labor Statistics and worked on the Consumer Price Index, which that year was rising so fast that people asked her about it at parties as though she were doing it to them. She said the number exactly. She did not tell her mother that the pot roast was good when it was not, and her husband no longer asked her about his haircuts. A man at a party in Ellicott City had once asked her whether she was enjoying herself, and she had told him, and he had not spoken to her since.

Ray Coffman did not steal. He was fifty, a contracting officer at the General Services Administration, in the branch that let out repair work on federal buildings. A grand jury in Washington had spent the past year looking into bribes on exactly those contracts, and men two doors down from Ray had been called to testify. Ray had nothing to tell them. When a contractor left a bottle of Canadian whisky on his desk at Christmas he sent it back by registered mail with a letter, and paid for the registered mail. He did not take pencils home. He kept a list of the personal telephone calls he made from his office and paid the cost of them into an envelope.

Gail Fennell did not go with another man. She was thirty-eight and worked at Housing and Urban Development. Her husband Tom had been told he had multiple sclerosis in 1975. He had stopped driving the next year and stopped working the year after, and he was home in Columbia all day in a chair by the window, doing the crossword in ink. There was a man in Gail's office who would have given up a good deal for her, and both of them knew it, and every evening at five-fifteen she got into the van.

Leon Matthews did not drink. He was forty-five and worked in the Wage and Hour Division at the Department of Labor, and on Sundays he

was a deacon in the Black Baptist congregation that shared the Wilde Lake interfaith center with the Catholics and the Methodists and the Lutherans, all of them taking turns in the same plain rooms. In the spring of 1971 he had come to in a ditch beside Route 40 with his car on its roof and the radio still playing, and he had not had a drink since. At the office Christmas party he held a ginger ale in a plastic cup all evening, so that no one would bring him anything.

Each of them had made a promise about one thing. Each of them kept it. And each of them believed, though none of them had ever said so out loud, that the thing he kept was the hardest of the five.

II. Odd and Even

July

By the middle of June there were lines at every station in Maryland, and the governor had put the state on odd and even. If your license plate ended in an odd number you bought gas on odd days, and if it ended in an even number, on even days. Carol had brought the executive order to the van in her purse to read them a line from it, because the state had thought it necessary to put in writing that zero is an even number.

The lines ran out of the stations and down the shoulders of the roads. Up in Levittown, Pennsylvania, people had thrown bottles at the police and set two cars on fire, chanting for gas. The van's plate was even, and Bernie bought his gas before daylight on even days and came home with the tank full, and on odd days the van went by the lines with its riders looking out at them.

On a Sunday night in the middle of July the President went on television and told the country it was having a crisis of confidence. On Monday morning the radio in the van played pieces of the speech over again, until Bernie turned it off.

One afternoon that week, going home, the van came to a stop on Colesville Road behind a line for a Sunoco station that had backed out of the lot and into the right-hand lane and up over the hill. It was in the

nineties. The van had no air conditioning that worked. They sat with the windows open and the engine off and the smell of everyone else's exhaust coming in.

Crisis of confidence, said Ray. *I'll tell you a crisis. Another man on my floor got a subpoena last week.*

At least you know what you're not supposed to do, said Walt. *Try not killing anything in Maryland in July.* He slapped his neck, looked at his palm, and showed it to them. A mosquito. *There. Every day I break it. Every day before lunch.*

Everybody lies forty times a day, Carol said. *How are you. Fine, thanks. I can't say fine, thanks. Do you know what that's like? You can't get through a grocery line.*

Nobody sees stealing, Ray said. *That's what makes it hard. You could take a box of envelopes home every night for thirty years and nobody would ever know but you. You have to be your own auditor.*

Every retirement lunch in my building, said Leon. *Every Friday at five. Somebody's always holding a door open on Fourteenth Street, and it's always cool in there, and somebody always says one won't hurt you, Leon.*

Gail had been looking out the window. *You all go home,* she said, *and nobody's waiting for you to make a mistake. That's all I'm going to say.*

Nobody answered her for a while. Then they all started again, louder, the way people do when someone has said the true thing and they would rather not have heard it. The man in the seat in front of them, who rode in from Long Reach and worked at the Smithsonian, put his newspaper over his face.

Bernie, said Ray finally. *Settle it. You've heard all of us for five years. Which one.*

III. The Driver

The same afternoon

Bernie did not turn around. He was watching the car in front, a Pinto with a dog in the back window, which had moved up about a length.

They're all hard, he said.

That's no answer, said Carol. *That's what you say to children.*

He started the engine and moved the van up a length behind the Pinto and turned it off again. There was a book on the dashboard, a library copy of Lincoln's speeches with a GAO routing slip in it for a marker. He read at red lights. Everyone in the van knew that, and nobody had ever asked him what. He reached the book back over the seat without looking and Leon took it.

Where the slip is, said Bernie. *Read them that.*

Leon looked at the page a while first, the way he would look over a Scripture before he read it out on a Sunday. It was a speech Lincoln had made in Springfield in 1842, to a society of reformed drunkards.

> *In my judgment, such of us as have never fallen victims, have been spared more from the absence of appetite, than from any mental or moral superiority over those who have.*
>
> *— Abraham Lincoln, Address to the Springfield Washingtonian Temperance Society, 1842*

I never took a drink, said Bernie. *Never wanted one. My father drank enough for the both of us at Sparrows Point for thirty years. So that one's easy for me, and it's no credit to me. I never had the appetite.* He watched the Pinto. *Walt, I'd have swatted your wasp and not thought twice. Carol, I tell my wife her coffee is fine every morning of my life. Whichever one you don't want, that one's easy. Whichever one you want, that's the hard one. It's the same for all five.*

So which is worst? said Ray, but quieter.

Any of them. You let any one of them go and you've dug yourself up by the roots. Doesn't matter which one. It's the same tree.

The line moved. The Pinto went up over the hill and the van went after it, and the attendant at the Sunoco was out in the road with a cardboard sign that said NO GAS, waving everyone on, and the whole line pulled out around him and went on north.

Nobody in the back said anything after that. Leon kept the book on his knee with his thumb in the page. Somewhere past the Beltway Gail fell

asleep against the window, which she had never done before, and Carol took off her own cardigan and folded it and put it between Gail's head and the glass.

• • •

The next morning, an odd day, a yellowjacket was in the van when Bernie unlocked it in the lot behind the village center. It had come in the night through the vent and was walking up and down the inside of the back window.

Walt went down the aisle with his paper cup. The yellowjacket would not go into it. It went up the glass and down, and along the rubber seal, and up again.

It was eleven minutes to seven, then ten to, then nine. Nobody said anything about the time. The man from Long Reach lowered his newspaper and watched. Carol held the back door open. Ray held a folded *Post* flat against the glass to make a wall, and Leon stood beside him and told Walt, *Easy, easy, you got him, no, there he goes.* Gail said nothing and kept her hand flat on the seat back, waiting.

Bernie sat behind the wheel with the engine running. He did not look at his watch. He watched the whole thing in the rearview mirror, until Walt came down the step with the cup closed under his palm and walked out across the parking lot to the strip of grass and the young trees at the edge of it, and opened his hand.

Background

The verses

> *He who destroys life, who speaks untruth, who in this world takes what is not given him, who goes to another man's wife;*
>
> Dhammapada 246, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *And the man who gives himself to drinking intoxicating liquors, he, even in this world, digs up his own root.*
>
> Dhammapada 247, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *O man, know this, that the unrestrained are in a bad state; take care that greediness and vice do not bring thee to grief for a long time!*
>
> Dhammapada 248, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a group of lay followers at Jetavana each keep one of the five precepts: one abstains from killing, another from lying, and so on. They fall into a dispute, each insisting that his own precept is the hard one, and take the question to the Buddha. He does not rank them, and says that every precept is hard to keep. The verses follow, naming all five wrongs together. Some texts number the disciples at five hundred; the translator notes that the story itself calls for five. Read the full commentary story.

Columbia, Maryland

Columbia, Maryland, *1979*

Columbia was founded in 1967 by the developer James Rouse as a planned town between Baltimore and Washington, meant to be free of racial, religious and class segregation. It was built as a set of villages, and its streets were named from poems and novels. Sohap Lane in Oakland Mills, for example, comes from a Carl Sandburg poem. Congregations shared buildings instead of building their own. The Wilde Lake Interfaith Center opened in 1971 for a Catholic parish, a Black Baptist church, a Methodist–Presbyterian church and a Lutheran congregation, and the Catholics took down their crucifix and Stations of the Cross whenever the room was needed for Rosh Hashanah.

The Iranian Revolution set off the 1979 oil crisis, with gas lines, panic buying, and riots in Levittown, Pennsylvania. Maryland put drivers on odd-even days. Its executive order, effective June 21, 1979, explained that "Zero is an even number." On July 15 President Carter gave his televised "crisis of confidence" address. The year before, federal grand juries had begun investigating fraud and bribery at the General Services Administration, including bribes on repair contracts for federal buildings in Washington. Bernie's bookmark is in Lincoln's address of February 22, 1842 to the

Springfield branch of the Washingtonians, a temperance movement begun by reformed drinkers.

After the story of the five lay disciples from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 246–248). The original. Scripture from Abraham Lincoln's address to the Springfield Washingtonian Temperance Society (1842). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.8

A Peck a Head

> *When we ask God to give us, the meaning is, that the thing asked is simply and freely the gift of God, whatever be the quarter from which it comes to us.*
> *— Calvin, Institutes III.xx.44, tr. Henry Beveridge (1845)*

Voici comme je l'ai ouï dire, at Manakin Town.

I. The Meal

Manakin Town, on the James River, Virginia · December 1700

They had been promised land on the Nansemond River, near the sea, and they had been put down instead on the old Monacan town, twenty-odd miles above the falls of the James, at the last edge of the English plantations. Beyond them there was nothing but woods, and somewhere in the woods the Monacan, who had gone away from these fields and might or might not come back. The sloop that carried most of their goods up from Jamestown had gone down in the river with their blankets in it. By December there were more than a hundred French in the huts on the old fields, and at one time or another most of them had been sick.

They lived on gifts. The Governor had sent a brief through the colony commending the poor distressed French Protestants to all charitable persons, and the parishes had answered, some generously and some not. Colonel Byrd's mill at Falling Creek ground Indian corn for them and sent it up the river road in sacks. A captain below the falls sent beeves, and corn from a widow's mill. A planter in Henrico sent a cask of salt pork with his name burned into the head. Twenty barrels of corn came from the Governor himself. Some weeks the sacks did not come at all, be-

cause there was no one to drive the carts, or the creeks were up, and then the old fields were very quiet.

The meal was kept in the common storehouse, which was the largest of the huts, and an elder of the consistory named Abraham Chabanne measured it out. He was seventy-one. Before he was a refugee he had been for thirty years the steward of a Protestant house in Poitou, the maître d'hôtel, the man who kept the keys and the household book and knew to the pound what every mouth in the place had eaten. When the family he served had gone to Mass in 1685 to keep their lands, he had put on his coat and walked out of the gate with one book and a change of linen. Now he sat at a plank table in the storehouse with a peck measure, a sack of Indian meal and a ledger he had ruled himself, and wrote in it, by each family's name, what they had been given and from whom.

On Sundays, when the minister was below the falls, prayers were read by a young man named Daniel Rigaud.

He was twenty-two. He read well, in a good voice, and he had some Latin and could lead a psalm. He had been made reader because nobody else wanted it and because he wanted it very much, and in the huts he was called, not always kindly, the little minister.

He found fault with the gifts. Everyone noticed it, after a while.

When the meal came up from Falling Creek coarse, he said the miller had ground it for hogs. When it came up fine, he said the English had sifted out the best for themselves. When a sack came half full, he said, *Is this what they think a Christian is worth? A peck a head, as if we were cattle?* And when a great load came at once, four carts in a day after the creeks went down, he stood in the door of the storehouse and said, *They have emptied out the bottom of their barns, what their own people would not eat, so as to be thanked for it in their churches. Who will carry all this? It will be wet before it is eaten.* He said the salt pork was rusty. He said the beef was all neck. He said that the pone the women baked in the ashes was a thing a French dog would turn its nose from, and when it was given him hot he said it was raw in the middle, and when it was given him cold he said it was a stone.

And when anyone would listen he spoke of his own people.

In my father's house at Niort, he said, *nobody ever went away hungry. The preachers of the Désert came through our door from all four quarters of the kingdom, in the worst years, with the dragoons on the roads, and my father kept a table for them all as if it were an inn. White bread. Wine of Saintonge. My mother would have been ashamed to give a guest what we are given here.*

The women at the fire looked at one another and said nothing. They had all eaten the Falling Creek meal and been glad of it. Some of them had watched their children eat nothing else for a month. But he was the reader, and he had Latin.

II. The Carpenters

January 1701

IT WAS THE YOUNG MEN WHO BEGAN TO WONDER ABOUT HIM, and two of them, Isaac Faure and a boy named Jean Sabatier, went to the elders about it.

He says his father kept a table for all the preachers in Poitou, said Isaac. *He says it every week. Has anybody here ever heard of such a house at Niort?*

Nobody had. They were from everywhere, from Languedoc and Dauphiné and the Saintonge, from the Vivarais and from Paris; there were Swiss among them, and Flemings, and a few Germans. Nobody was from Niort.

So the elders asked Daniel himself, at the storehouse table, as if in passing, where his people were.

At Niort, he said. *Behind the market hall. Anyone there would show you the house.*

And how did you come out of France?

With some others. On foot to Geneva. He looked at the ledger in front of Chabanne. *It was a hard road. I don't speak of it.*

There was a family of joiners who had come over on the same ship as Daniel, the Vidal brothers, from Saint-Jean-d'Angély, and they had not come up to the old fields at all. They had gone to work for wages on a plantation below the falls, building a tobacco house for an English planter, because a joiner could get paid in Virginia and nobody was paying

anybody at Manakin Town. It was said that they had walked out of France together with Daniel.

Isaac and Jean went down to them on foot. It took them two days on the river road, over the creeks on logs, and they slept the night at Falling Creek in the mill, where the miller's people gave them hominy and a place by the stones. On the second afternoon they found the Vidals on the roof frame of the tobacco house, and the elder Vidal came down the ladder with his adze in his hand and listened to the question with his head on one side.

Daniel? he said. *Daniel Rigaud, of Niort?* He began to laugh, and then he called up to his brothers, and they began to laugh too.

His father is the porter at the gate of the Hôtel de Bessac, he said, *behind the market hall. He has a lodge the size of this ladder, with a bench in it and a brazier. He opens the gate when the carriage comes and shuts it when the carriage goes. That's the house he means. As for the preachers,* he said, and stopped laughing, *maybe. A porter's lodge can hide a man for a night. I wouldn't know.*

Did he walk out with you?

He carried our glue pot from Saint-Jean to Geneva. He was fourteen. We had a company of nine, all carpenters, and he begged to come because he was afraid of the dragoons, and we let him. He was a good boy on the road. He looked up at his brothers on the frame. *Never said a word about any table then. He was glad of anything.*

The two young men went back up the river road. On the second night, sitting in the mill at Falling Creek with the stones still and the sacks for Manakin Town stacked by the door, Jean Sabatier said, *I don't like doing this.*

Neither do I, said Isaac.

They told the elders all of it, in the storehouse, with the door shut. *He talks for nothing,* said Isaac at the end. *There's no house. There was never any wine of Saintonge. He chatters, that's all, and we have all been listening to him.*

The elders sat a while. Then one of them said what they were all thinking, which was that it was a matter for Abraham Chabanne.

III. The Steward

That night

The old man was sitting on a sack by the storehouse fire with his ledger on his knees. He had heard all of it already, because he had been sitting at the table the whole time with his back to them and his pen in his hand.

It isn't the first time, he said.

He has done this before?

Not this boy. The same boy. He shut the ledger. *I have known that boy in three houses and on one ship. He is always clever, and he always reads well, and he always finds the soup too hot. I knew him first in La Rochelle, when I was younger than you, Isaac. Do you want to hear about him?*

They did. They pulled the sacks around. Somebody put another stick on the fire. And the old steward told it to them the way he told the household book, in order, leaving nothing out.

IV. The Letter

La Rochelle and the Saintonge, in the old days

There was a merchant in La Rochelle, he said, before the siege was forgotten and before the Revocation, a shipowner of the Religion named Monsieur Élie Bonnaud, and I was a boy in his kitchen. On the same day his wife gave birth to a son, a servant of the house gave birth to one too. The servant called hers Valentin. The two boys grew up in the same house, the one upstairs and the other down.

When the young master was sent to his letters, Valentin carried his satchel and his slate to the master's house and back, and sat on the stair outside the room while the young master was taught. He learned to write on the stair, by listening, with a stick in the dust. He learned it better than the young master did. In the end Monsieur Bonnaud took him into the counting house to copy letters, and then made him his own secretary, because he had the best hand in La Rochelle, and because he was handsome and well spoken, and the merchants liked to deal with him.

And Valentin thought to himself, said Chabanne: I will not always be kept at this. One blot, one wrong word, and I'll be beaten or put out in the street, and fed on what servants are fed. Monsieur has a friend, a salt merchant at Marennes, out among the marshes, who has never seen Monsieur's son. Why shouldn't I go to him with a letter from Monsieur, and be Monsieur's son, and marry the salt merchant's daughter, and live like a gentleman?

So he wrote the letter in his master's name. *The bearer is my son. It is fitting that our houses be joined. I would have you give him your daughter, and keep the young people by you for the present, and I will come to you as soon as I may.* He sealed it with Monsieur Bonnaud's own seal, whose drawer he had the key to, and he took a purse of his master's money and a good coat and a bottle of orange-flower water, and he rode out to Marennes.

The salt merchant read the letter and said it gave him new life. Within the month Valentin was married to his daughter Suzanne, and set up in a house on the square with a maid and a horse.

And from the first day, said the old steward, he found fault with everything they brought him.

Provincial, he said. The fish was provincial, and the bread, and the way his wife's mother dressed her hair, and the scent the women wore to church. *You people,* he said at table, *have no idea how anything is done.*

In La Rochelle Monsieur Bonnaud missed his secretary and sent men to look for him, and in time they found him at Marennes and came back without his ever knowing them. Monsieur heard them out. *This won't do,* he said. *I'll go myself and bring him back.* And word went out along the coast that the great Monsieur Bonnaud of La Rochelle was riding out to the salt country with his household.

I rode with him, said Chabanne. I was nineteen, and I carried the bags.

Now Valentin heard the news and sat down to think. He could not run, because if he ran he could never come back. So he decided to go and meet his master on the road and win him over by serving him, as he had served him all his life. And first he made his ground ready. For two weeks, at every table in Marennes, he talked about the decay of respect for fathers in the provinces. *Here,* he said, *I see sons sit down at their father's*

table and eat with him, as if they were his equals. In La Rochelle a son stands behind his father's chair. He pours his wine. He brings the basin and the towel. He does not sit until he is told. That is how I was raised. He talked about it until the whole town knew how a son of La Rochelle served his father. Then he said to his father-in-law, *I hear my father is coming to see you. Make ready for him. I will go out and meet him on the road with a present.*

He met us a day out, said the old steward, with a cart behind him and a fine horse for a present, and he bowed to the ground. Monsieur Bonnaud took the horse very kindly. At noon we stopped, and Monsieur went aside into the trees to relieve himself, and Valentin sent the rest of us back and took the ewer of water and the towel and went after him himself, as a servant would. I saw it, because I was holding the horses. He went down on his knees in the leaves at his master's feet. *Monsieur, I will pay you anything you name. Only don't expose me.*

Fear nothing from me, said Monsieur Bonnaud. He was pleased that the boy had brought the water.

So we rode into Marennes, and there was a great dinner, and Valentin stood behind his master's chair all evening and poured his wine and brought the basin, and the whole town nodded at one another. The salt merchant said, *Monsieur, on the strength of your letter I gave your son my daughter.* And Monsieur Bonnaud answered him about his son so graciously that the old man wept into his napkin.

But from that day on, said Chabanne, Monsieur could not bear to look at him.

Before we left he sent for the daughter, Suzanne, and asked her to comb out his hair for him, as a daughter would, because his own hands were stiff. While she combed it he asked her how she did, and whether her husband was a reasonable man, and whether they got on.

He has one fault, Monsieur, she said. *He finds fault with his food.*

He always did, said Monsieur Bonnaud. *But I will tell you how to stop his mouth.* And he taught her a few words, and made her say them over until she had them by heart, and told her to say them to her husband the next time he complained at table. Then he gave her a ring off his own hand, and the next morning we rode home to La Rochelle. Valentin rode a good

way out with us and gave Monsieur more presents, and bowed in the road until we were out of sight.

After we were gone, said the old man, he grew prouder than ever, because he thought the danger was past. And one evening Suzanne had a fine dinner made for him, and served him herself with the spoon, and at the first mouthful he began.

She put down the spoon, and she said it to him the way she had been taught.

When a man has gone into another country and talked very big, the one he left behind may come one day and spoil it all. Eat your dinner, Valentin.

Chabanne stopped there.

What did he do? said Jean Sabatier.

He ate his dinner, said the old man. *He knew then who had taught her. He never said another word about a dish in that house as long as he lived. I saw him once, years after, at the fair at Saint-Jean. He had grown fat, and he looked well, and he kept his eyes down when he saw me.*

V. Daily Bread

The same night, and the first of February

THE YOUNG MEN WERE QUIET A WHILE.

So he is Valentin, said Isaac. *And we are to say so? At prayers? Before everyone?*

No, said Chabanne. *Monsieur Bonnaud didn't. Nobody is to say anything to him. It's not his father's lodge that is the trouble with him. Plenty of good men have been porters.* He opened his ledger again on his knees, and from inside the back board he took a little book, very worn, with a brass clasp. It was the Institution of Master Calvin, in French, the one book he had carried out of the gate in Poitou. He did not need to look for the place.

Listen. Master Calvin is speaking of the bread we ask for in the Lord's Prayer. Of what it is to be given anything at all.

He read it in French, and slowly.

> *When we ask God to give us, the meaning is, that the thing asked is simply and freely the gift of God, whatever be the quarter from which it comes to us, even when it seems to have been specially prepared by our own art and industry, and procured by our hands, since it is to his blessing alone that all our labours owe their success.*
>
> *— Calvin, Institutes III.xx.44, tr. Henry Beveridge (1845)*

Whatever the quarter, said the old man. *Colonel Byrd's mill. The widow's mill. That planter with his name burned in his cask. Every one of them gives as his heart gives, more or less, coarse or fine, and some of them for the wrong reasons, and every one of them is the hand God has chosen this week to feed us. Our boy cannot eat a mouthful without first weighing what was put in another man's bowl, and where it came from, and whether it was enough, and whether it was too much.* He ran his finger back up the page. *And just before, Master Calvin says that the Lord can take the strength out of bread, so that a man eats and is not fed.*

> *In like manner, whenever it so pleases, he gives us a proof of an opposite description, by breaking the strength, or, as he himself calls it, the staff of bread, (Levit. xxvi. 26,) and leaving us even while eating to pine with hunger, and while drinking to be parched with thirst.*
>
> *— Calvin, Institutes III.xx.44, tr. Henry Beveridge (1845)*

I have watched him at it since the summer, said Chabanne. *He eats, and he is hungry. He doesn't sleep. He doesn't pray, he reads. A man who frets at what is given can't be still, not by day and not by night. And the one who gets that out of himself by the root, the whole of it, he can be still anywhere. Even here. Even on Indian meal.* He shut the book and closed the clasp. *Now go to bed, both of you. And thank the miller, when you see him next.*

• • •

The sacks came up from Falling Creek on the first of the month, five carts of them, as had been settled: a bushel a head, which is a peck a week. The whole of the old town came to the storehouse in a line that

went out the door and along the path between the huts in the snow, and Abraham Chabanne sat at the plank table with the measure and the ledger and called the names.

He called them in the order of the book, family by family. He filled the measure and struck it level with the edge of a board, and tipped it into the bag or the pot or the apron that was held out to him, and wrote it down. When he came to the name of Daniel Rigaud, reader, he filled the measure and struck it level the same as for anyone, and poured it into the young man's sack.

Daniel looked at the meal. Somebody behind him in the line had said, quite loudly, that this lot was coarse.

The old steward did not look up. He wet his pen.

Eat your dinner, Daniel, he said, and wrote it in the book.

The young man stood there holding the sack. Then he went out past the line into the snow without a word, and the next one stepped up to the table, and the old man called the next name.

Background

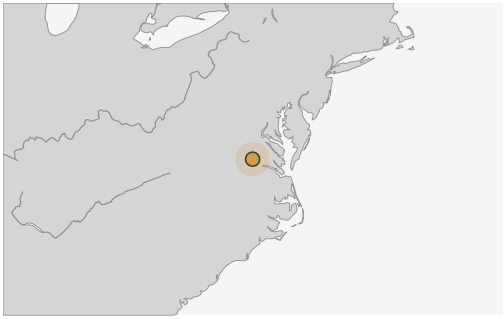
The verses

> *The world gives according to their faith or according to their pleasure: if a man frets about the food and the drink given to others, he will find no rest either by day or by night.*
>
> Dhammapada 249, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He in whom that feeling is destroyed, and taken out with the very root, finds rest by day and by night.*
>
> Dhammapada 250, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the young monk Tissa finds fault with every gift the great lay supporters give the monks. Cold food is too cold and hot food is too hot. A small gift is stingy, and a large one is waste. Meanwhile he boasts that his own kinsfolk keep open house for monks from all four quarters. The monks send young monks to his village to ask, and the villagers tell them that no son of a good family ever went forth from there, only a gatekeeper's son who left traveling with some carpenters. The Buddha says Tissa was a braggart in a past life too, and tells the birth story of

Kaṭāhaka. Kaṭāhaka was a slave who learned to write by carrying his young master's tablets. He forged a letter under his master's seal and married a merchant's daughter on the frontier, and there he scorned everything as provincial. When his master came, Kaṭāhaka waited on him and begged not to be exposed. The master kept the secret, but he taught the young wife a verse to say whenever her husband found fault with his food. The verses on giving follow. Read the full commentary story, or about the Jātaka birth stories.



Manakin Town, Virginia

Manakin Town, 1700–1701

When Louis XIV revoked the Edict of Nantes with the Edict of Fontainebleau in 1685, after years of dragonnades that quartered soldiers on Protestant households, at least two hundred thousand Huguenots fled France. In 1700 and 1701 several hundred of them sailed from London to Virginia on five ships. They had been promised land on the Nansemond River. Governor Francis Nicholson and the Council settled them instead at Manakin Town, on ground the Monacan had left, about twenty miles above the falls of the James. The first sloop carrying their goods sank at Jamestown, sickness ran through the camps, and for seven years the new King William Parish was excused from levies, owing only a ripe ear of Indian corn if one was demanded.

The colony kept them alive on charity. Nicholson issued a brief commending the "poor distress'd Christian brethren" to all charitable persons, and subscribers gave pork, wheat, tobacco and corn, twenty barrels of it from the Governor himself. Planters sent beeves and corn, and in February 1701 the refugees began drawing one bushel of Indian meal a head each month from William Byrd's mill at Falling Creek. Their leaders quarreled bitterly with the minister Benjamin de Joux over goods and accounts. That May, Byrd rode up to see them and reported that, though very poor, "they seem very cheerful," and "all they seem to desire is y't they might have Bread enough." These documents are printed in R. A. Brock's *Documents, Chiefly Unpublished, Relating to the Huguenot Emigration to Virginia* (1886). Abraham Chabanne's book is Calvin's Institution, which Calvin himself put into French in 1541.

After the story of the young monk Tissa and the birth story of Kaṭāhaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 249–250). The original. Scripture from Calvin's *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, translated by Henry Beveridge (1845). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.9

Fire Year

> *Before the Soul can hear, the image (man) has to become as deaf to roarings as to whispers, to cries of bellowing elephants as to the silvery buzzing of the golden fire-fly.*
> *— H. P. Blavatsky, The Voice of the Silence (1889)*

Así me lo contaron, on the East End.

I. The Gate

The East End of the Ojai Valley · Wednesday, December 6, 2017

THE WHOLE VALLEY WAS UNDER EVACUATION ORDERS BY WEDnesday afternoon, and five men were standing at the bottom of a ranch road off Highway 150 to watch the fire come.

It had started Monday night north of Santa Paula, a few miles over the hill, and the Santa Ana wind had taken it twelve miles to the sea in a few hours and burned the hillsides above Ventura. Now it had turned and come up the valley behind Black Mountain, and the mountains around Ojai that the town loved for going pink at sunset were black along the ridges and orange in the folds. The sun was a red coin. Ash came down like a slow gray snow on the windshields and the tangerine leaves. The hydrants in town had gone dry the day before when the fire got into the pumps.

Captain Maricela Ochoa pulled her engine off the highway at the ranch gate because she had seen the five of them standing there and she knew every one of them by name.

She was fifty-one. She had grown up in Santa Paula, where her father had picked lemons for forty years, and she had been in the fire service for twenty-six of hers. She spread the map on the warm hood of the engine.

Her probationary firefighter, a boy from Camarillo named Noah, stood beside her and waved his clipboard back and forth over the map to keep the ash off it.

Then she told them.

She told them where the fire was and where it would be at dark. She told them what the wind would do when it came over the ridge after midnight, what the embers would do a mile ahead of it, and that there was no water in the hydrants and no engine coming to their road, because there were not enough engines in the state. She told them what happens to a house with a wood shake roof and what happens to a man in a house when the air outside it is a thousand degrees. She did not raise her voice. She talked to them the way she would have talked to her own brothers, and Noah, who had heard her give a dozen briefings, said afterward that it went through you like cold water, that the hair stood up on his arms. It was the plainest talk he ever heard and he could have stood in the ash and listened to it all night.

The five men stood around the hood.

Lionel Strand, who had written music for the movies for thirty years and had a house up the canyon with a view of the whole valley, sat down in the canvas camp chair he had brought, and before she was done he was asleep, his chin on his chest, in the red light.

Gil Haskins, who grew organic Pixie tangerines on twenty acres and raised his own compost worms in long beds under the trees, squatted at the edge of the road while she talked and worked one finger into the dry ground, and then another, down to the second knuckle, feeling for the damp that was not there.

Brent Kessler, who had surfed for money once and now sold houses to people from Los Angeles, stood with one hand around the trunk of a young live oak by the gate, and shook it. He did not know he was doing it. The leaves rattled the whole time.

Teo Lindqvist, who kept an astrology practice upstairs on Ojai Avenue, stood with his head back and watched the smoke column over Sulphur Mountain build itself into a white tower and flatten at the top, a cloud the fire was making for itself. Saturn would go into Capricorn in two

weeks. He had been telling his clients for a year that December would be a reckoning, and now he watched the sky to see how.

And Arthur Penrose, who was eighty-six and lived in a little French-style cottage beside the Theosophists' grounds on the west side of town, and who had come out to the East End that morning to help a friend load her horses and stayed because no one had told him to go home, stood with his hands folded in front of him and listened. He listened as if he were taking it down. For forty years he had been a court reporter in Los Angeles, and before that, for as long as he could remember, he had been a student of one small book, which he could say from beginning to end. He did not take his eyes off her face.

When she was done she folded the map. *That's it,* she said. *Go now.*

Mr. Penrose said *Thank you, Captain,* and walked to his car. The other four did not move.

II. Five Hundred Times

Highway 150 · the same afternoon

NOAH WAITED UNTIL THEY WERE BACK ON THE HIGHWAY.

Cap. That was the best one I've heard you do. It was like a thunderstorm. And they stood there. One of them was asleep. One of them was playing in the dirt.

You don't know those men?

No, ma'am.

She drove for a while. The ash came down on the windshield and the wipers smeared it.

I've been up Lionel Strand's road four times since 1990, she said. *Two fires and two times his smoke alarm went off. Every time, he was asleep. He paid a woman on Ojai Avenue a hundred and fifty dollars to read his past lives, and she told him he'd been a snake five hundred times in a row, curled up on a warm rock, asleep. He tells it at parties. He thinks it's funny.* She looked at Noah. *I think she earned her money.*

Gil Haskins, she said, *has been digging in that dirt since he was born. Ask him what he was before, he'll tell you. A worm. Five hundred times. He says it*

like it's a compliment, and maybe it is. But he can't hear you with his hands in the ground.

Kessler. You saw him with the tree. That one never stands still. Teo did his chart for him, and Teo told him he'd been a monkey for five hundred lives. Kessler had it printed on a T-shirt.

And Teo?

Teo did his own. He was an astrologer. Five hundred lives. Looking up. She almost smiled. *He's still looking up. There's a fire coming down the hill at him and he's reading it like a horoscope.*

The old man listened.

Mr. Penrose says he was a priest in India for five hundred lives, and all he did in every one of them was chant the same holy book. Over and over, to get every word right. I believe him. He's the only one of them that heard me. He listens like he's writing down a scripture.

Noah was quiet. Then he said, *But it goes right through you. The way you say it. How can somebody stand there and not hear that?*

You think it's easy to hear?

Isn't it?

No, she said. *It's the hardest thing there is.*

Why?

She did not answer right away. They passed a horse trailer with its doors open in a field and nobody near it. A whole orchard on the slope to their left was burning in a quiet line, tree by tree, like candles being lit down a row.

Because they've been listening to something else their whole lives, she said. *Their whole lives and, if you believe them, five hundred before that. The radio in the truck. The parties. The music. Their own selves talking. You come along and say one true thing and it's one more noise.*

But why? he said. *What's the noise?*

She pointed up the hill with her chin.

When I started, fire season ended with the first rain. Halloween, Thanksgiving. Now it's December and look at it. Now the old guys say there's no fire season, there's a fire year. But even this one goes out. This one needs the Santa Anas and months without rain. The rain comes, January, February, and it goes

out. There's another fire that doesn't need any of that. It burns in every one of those men every day of the year, and it doesn't leave ashes. There's no fire like wanting. There's nothing that grabs hold of a man like hating somebody. There's no trap like not seeing what's right in front of you. And no flood like always wanting more.

Noah looked at the hill.

You wait, she said. *After this fire comes the mud.*

III. The Night

The East End · December 6–7

THE WIND CAME OVER THE RIDGE AFTER MIDNIGHT, THE WAY she had said.

Lionel Strand went back up his canyon and sat down in his living room in front of the big window to watch the fire, and fell asleep. At three in the morning Captain Ochoa's crew, going up the canyon road against orders with the cab full of smoke, found him in his chair with the window glowing orange in front of him and carried him out to the engine, still mostly asleep. The house burned an hour later. He said afterward that he had dreamed of a warm rock.

Gil Haskins stayed in his orchard all night with a shovel, digging a firebreak around his trees in ground too hard to dig. The embers went over him and the break and into the windbreak of eucalyptus. He lost eleven of his twenty acres. In the morning he was still digging.

Brent Kessler drove back and forth on Highway 150 until four in the morning, from one roadblock to the other, unable to stay anywhere, calling everyone he knew. His listings burned. His own house did not.

Teo Lindqvist stood on the roof of his building on Ojai Avenue and watched the column over the mountains until it collapsed in on itself before dawn and threw a wind down the valley that rattled every window on the avenue. He said later that he had seen a face in it. He would not say whose.

IV. The Mineral Building

Ventura County Fairgrounds · December 7

Arthur Penrose spent the night on a Red Cross cot in the Mineral Building at the fairgrounds in Ventura, between a family from Casitas Springs with three children and a man who had brought only his cat. The ocean was a block away. You could hear it under the sound of the generators.

He did not sleep. He sat on the edge of the cot in his good overcoat with his hands folded, and he said the book over to himself, the way he had said it every night since 1952, when a woman at a lecture in Pasadena had given him a copy and told him to learn it by heart. He knew every word of it. He had always known every word of it. He had taken down eight million words in courtrooms and he had never once misheard one.

Somewhere around the second fragment, at a passage he had said perhaps twenty thousand times, he heard it.

> *If thou would'st cross the first Hall safely, let not thy mind mistake the fires of lust that burn therein for the Sunlight of life.*
>
> *— H. P. Blavatsky, The Voice of the Silence (1889), Fragment I*

He heard it in a woman's voice, flat and plain, the voice of somebody leaning on the hood of a fire engine with ash coming down on her shoulders. It was not a book. It was a report of what was on the hill. It had always been a report of what was on the hill, and he had been reciting it the way you recite the weather in another country. He sat on the cot and said the next lines, slowly, and they were true too.

> *This light shines from the jewel of the Great Ensnarer, (Mara). The senses it bewitches, blinds the mind, and leaves the unwary an abandoned wreck.*
>
> *The moth attracted to the dazzling flame of thy night-lamp is doomed to perish in the viscid oil.*
>
> *— The Voice of the Silence, Fragment I*

The man with the cat asked if he was all right. He said yes. He said he had just understood something he had known for sixty-five years, and the man nodded, as if that happened all the time in the Mineral Building, and maybe it did.

Toward morning the wind turned and blew in off the water, and the smoke lifted for an hour. Mr. Penrose went out and stood in the parking lot, an old man in an overcoat among the horse trailers, and looked north at the burning hills. It seemed to him that he was seeing them for the first time without anything in between: the fire, the hill, the people on the cots behind him, his own two hands. Whatever starts, ends. He had said that to himself all his life too.

V. The Mud

Highway 150 · January 9, 2018

The first real rain of the season came on the eighth of January, and it fell all night on the black hills. Captain Ochoa was on Highway 150 before dawn on the ninth with a pickup and a shovel, watching the culverts below the burn, because she had said she would.

Over the mountain in Montecito the hills came down in the dark onto houses where people were asleep, and twenty-one of them died. On the East End the creeks ran thick as wet cement for two days, carrying burned oak limbs, boulders the size of cars, somebody's mailbox. They filled the culverts to the brim.

Mr. Penrose came out on the second day in his overcoat with an umbrella, and stood beside her on the shoulder of the highway, and they watched the creek go by. He did not say anything about the book. He asked about her father. She told him about the lemons.

Below them in the rain a black orchard stood in rows, eleven acres of it, every tree burned to the trunk. At the far end Gil Haskins was already out with his shovel in the mud, turning over the wet ground under the first dead tree, looking for worms.

Background

The verse

> *There is no fire like passion, there is no shark like hatred, there is no snare like folly, there is no torrent like greed.*
>
> Dhammapada 251, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five lay followers sit down to hear the Buddha teach. One falls asleep, one digs at the ground with his finger, one shakes a tree, and one gazes at the sky; only one listens. When Ānanda asks why, the Buddha tells him that for five hundred lives the first was a snake that slept in its coils, the second an earthworm, the third a monkey, the fourth an astrologer, and the fifth a brahmin who recited the Vedas, so each still does what he has always done. The Dhamma is hard to hear, he says, because of passion, hatred and delusion. The fire at the end of an age burns only in its season, but there is no season when the fire of passion does not burn. The listener enters the stream. Read the full commentary story.

Ojai, California

The Ojai Valley, 2017-2018

The Thomas Fire started on the evening of December 4, 2017, north of Santa Paula, and under unusually strong and long-lasting Santa Ana winds it ran twelve miles to Ventura in a few hours. It reached Black Mountain above Ojai, the whole valley was put under evacuation orders, and the town's water system stopped working for a time when the fire damaged its pumps. By the time it was contained on January 12, 2018, it had burned 281,893 acres, then the largest wildfire in modern California history, and its column had made its own weather. The first measurable rain fell on January 8; the next morning debris flows came down out of the burn scar onto Montecito and killed at least 21 people. Evacuees from Ventura and the Ojai Valley sheltered in the Mineral Building at the Ventura County Fairgrounds. Captain Ochoa, the five men and their houses are invented.

Ojai has drawn seekers for a century. The Theosophical colony of Krotona moved there from Hollywood in 1926, and theosophists later built the Taormina cottages beside it as a retirement community. Jiddu Krishnamurti settled in the valley in 1922 and died there in 1986. The town is known for its organic citrus, especially the small Ojai Pixie tangerine, and for the "pink moment" when the setting sun lights the Topatopa Mountains. Mr. Penrose's book is The Voice of the Silence, which Helena Blavatsky published in 1889 as a translation of verses she said she had learned by heart. Its first fragment describes three Halls the disciple must cross, and warns against the fires of lust and the light of Mara, the Ensnarer.

After the story of the five lay disciples from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 251). The original. Scripture from H. P. Blavatsky, *The Voice of the Silence* (1889). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

18.10

Seven Furrows

> *Why do you see the speck that is in your brother's eye, but don't consider the beam that is in your own eye?*
> *— Matthew 7:3*

Now the way I got it, north of the Canadian.

I. The Cutters

Fortune, Ochiltree County, Texas · June 2025

The Ensz crew came up out of Oklahoma on a Sunday night with four combines on trailers, two grain carts, six trucks and a cook camper. They had started cutting below Vernon in May and would finish at the Canadian line in September. Nolan Ensz had bossed the outfit since he was twenty-four, the year his father died in the cab. He was thirty-one now and from Inman, Kansas. He had nine hands, and five of them were South African farm boys on summer papers.

At supper in Shattuck he had told the crew there were six people north of the Canadian River he meant to see on this trip. He named them. They were R.L. Ramsey and his wife Lily, their son Win and his wife Jessie, a granddaughter called Vi who was seven, and the hired man, Fuller. He had never met any of them.

He put the campers in the row of Chinese elms on the east side of Fortune, where cutters had always stopped. By Monday noon R.L. Ramsey knew he was there.

II. The Rams

The Ramsey place · the same week

Now, as to the name. It was Ramsey before there was anything behind the house, and people say the one came looking for the other.

Behind the house are eight acres of bare caliche inside a pipe fence. In it are rams made of gold. They are the size of horses, and some run to the size of a good bull. They go at each other back to back all day and all night, and they have the ground torn up like a feedlot. Two men from Maine walked around among them one summer and came out without much to say.

Each ram carries a ball of yarn in its mouth, wound of five colors. When something is wanted on the place, somebody goes out and takes the ball from the mouth of one ram. Then whatever was wanted comes out after it. It may be butter or cooking oil, honey or sorghum, work shirts or quilts, or gold in bars or in coin. It comes until there is enough for everybody from the Rio Grande to the Canadian line, and when the ball is put back it stops. Vi is not allowed in the pen. She has a peacock that follows her as far as the gate and waits.

How a family comes by a thing like that is two stories, an old one and a hard one.

III. The Horse Shed

The same ground · 1904

The first R.L. Ramsey came into that country as a young man. He had an uncle of the same name who was already there. In 1904 the uncle undertook to build the first meeting house on that flat. The nephew went to him and asked to go in on it.

I would rather not share it, the uncle said. *I'll build it by myself.*

So the nephew built across the wagon road from it. A preacher in that day came horseback forty miles, and what the nephew built was a shed for the preacher's horse. He hauled cedar from the breaks for the posts.

He turned every post and worked every rafter, and people came from Lipscomb County to look at a horse shed. Under the roof, for the hot months, he made a preaching stand, and on the stand a chair. Under the four legs of the chair he carved four rams lying down. He put two more under the footboard and six on posts in a ring around it.

When it was done he held a meeting that ran four months. He fed everybody who came, and on the last day he gave each preacher a suit of clothes, down to the boys who led the singing.

That was the old story. The shed went in the fire of 1919, and the family kept one ram for a doorstop.

IV. The Wheat in the Walls

The same ground · 1931 to 1935

The hard one begins in July of 1931. That was the biggest wheat crop the plains had ever cut. It brought a quarter a bushel at the elevator in Perryton when the elevator would take it at all, and there were piles of it on the ground along the Santa Fe siding.

R.L. Ramsey, the nephew's son, was going in to the bank one morning. On the street he met old Krause, who kept the government rain gauge and read the sky for anybody who asked.

Are you studying the weather, Mr. Krause?

I am. What else have I got to do?

How is the country going to fare?

There's a bad time coming.

What kind?

It will quit raining, and people will go hungry.

When?

Three years.

R.L. went home and sowed every acre he had. He took what money he had and bought wheat with it, at a quarter and then at twenty cents, from men who thought he had lost his mind and were glad to see him coming. He built granaries of board and tin until there were a hundred and twenty-five of them on the section, in rows like a town. When they were

full he filled barrels and lard cans and washtubs. When those were full he dug a pit, lined it with roofing tin, filled it and covered it over. There was wheat left even then. He had it mixed into adobe mud by the wagonload and plastered the house and the barn with it, inside and out, a hand thick.

It quit raining. The dust began in 1932. By 1934 the government was buying starved cattle at sixteen dollars a head and shooting them in the draws. R.L. fed his own place out of the granaries, and his hands, and whoever came up the road. The last granary was swept in January of 1935. He called the hands together. There were fourteen of them.

Go to the mountains, he said. *Go to New Mexico or Colorado, or wherever there's water. When there's plenty here again, come back if you want to. If you'd rather not, stay where you like.*

They went. One stayed, and that was Fuller. With R.L., his wife Lily, their son Win and Win's wife Jessie, that made five on the place.

They ate the barrels and the cans and the tubs. They ate the pit down to the tin. Then they began on the walls. They knocked the plaster off with a hatchet, soaked it in the stock tank and skimmed the wheat as it came loose. They did the barn, and then the house from the outside, and then the house from the inside, a room at a time.

On the second Sunday of April, Lily broke out the last of it from behind the cookstove. She soaked it and got a coffee can of wheat. She put that through the coffee mill and had one pound of meal. There were men on the road in those months who had nothing, and she was afraid of them. She put the meal in a lard can, dug a hole in the cellar floor and buried it.

R.L. came in at noon from Perryton, where the bank had told him what it had to tell him.

Lily, I'm hungry. Is there anything?

She did not say there was nothing. *There's a pound of meal.*

Where?

In the cellar floor. I was afraid of the road.

Dig it up and cook some.

If I make mush of it, it's two meals. If I bake it, it's one. How do you want it?

We'll eat bread and die. Bake it.

She baked one pan, cut it in five and set R.L.'s piece in front of him.

There was a man that country knew of and seldom saw. He kept to himself on a mesa out past Tucumcari. He belonged to no church and did not preach. It was said he would sit a week at a time without food or motion, and get up from it as hungry as a man pulled out of a well. He got up that Sunday. He looked the country over, the way he could, and saw a kitchen in Ochiltree County with five people in it and one pan of bread. He wondered if they had it in them. He thought they did. He took his coat and a lard pail and stood at the Ramsey door.

R.L. saw him through the screen and was glad. *I have come to this because I never gave when I had it,* he thought. *This piece keeps me till tomorrow. Given, it keeps me longer than I can count.* He brought the man in and sat him down, washed his feet in the dishpan and put a stool under them. Then he took his piece and began to break it into the pail.

When half was in, the man put his hand over the pail.

Sir, said R.L., *we five had a pound of meal. This is one fifth of what it made, and it won't go in halves. I'm not asking you for any good out of it now. I want you to have it all.* He put the rest in. Then he said what he wanted.

Let me never see a time like this again, here or anyplace I come to. Let me have seed wheat for this whole country. Let me not have to scratch for my living. Let me sweep my granaries and wash my head and sit down in the granary door, and when I look up let red wheat come down and fill them. And wherever I come to, let this be my wife, and this my son, and this my son's wife, and this my hired man.

Lily thought that she could not eat with her husband hungry. She gave hers. *Let me never see a time like this again. Let me set one quart pot in front of me and feed this whole country from it, and as long as I keep my seat let it stay full. And let these be mine, the same ones.*

Win gave his. *Let me carry one purse with a thousand dollars in it, and pay out to everybody that needs it, and let it stay full. And let these be mine.*

Jessie gave hers. *Let me set down one basket of seed wheat and give seed to this whole country, and let it not go down. And let these be mine.*

Fuller gave his. *When I plow, let seven furrows open. Three on this side of me, three on that side and one in the middle, every one a full furrow wide.* It is held in that country that Fuller could have asked for the bank that day, or for the county, and had it. What he said was, *And let these be the people I work for.*

Let it be so, the man said to each of them. He said a few words of thanks over the pail. Then it came to him that they ought to have something to look at.

Watch me until I am home, he said.

He went up off the porch to about the height of the windmill and went west. It was the clearest morning of that spring, as everyone who lived through that day remembers. The five of them stood in the yard and watched him across the whole Panhandle to a mesa that cannot be seen from Ochiltree County. They saw him sit down there among five hundred like himself and divide five pieces of bread, and they saw that it went around.

After a while Lily went in, washed the pan, laid a dish towel over it and put it up. R.L. lay down on the bed with his boots on and slept.

Toward evening the birds came over, going south, and behind them came the thing that gave that Sunday its name. It stood across the whole north, black to the top of the sky, and when it reached the house the day went out. R.L. woke in the dark.

Lily. I'm hungry. Aren't there any burnt crusts left in that pan?

She knew she had washed it. She did not say there were none. *I'll look and tell you,* she said.

She felt her way to the shelf. The towel had lifted. The pan was full of bread to above the rim, warm, and through all the dust in that kitchen it smelled like rain.

Get up, R.L., she said. *I washed that pan and put it away. Get up and eat. It pays to do right. It pays to give.*

She fed her husband and her son. When they were done she and Jessie sat down and ate. Then she called Fuller in. For every piece that was lifted out there was a piece in its place.

In the morning the dust lay drifted to the windowsills, and every granary on the section was full to the door. R.L. had a notice put in the Perryton paper. *Wheat at Ramsey's. Anyone in need of seed, come.* They came in trucks and wagons from five states.

V. The Same Five

The Ramsey place · 1978 and after

THERE HAS BEEN AN R.L. RAMSEY ON THAT GROUND EVER since, with a wife called Lily, a son called Win who marries a Jessie, and a Fuller for a hired man. The family has a photograph from 1936 that visitors take for last year's Christmas card. Nobody in Fortune argues about it.

The rams were first seen behind the house in 1978, the week the present R.L. brought home Lily Mooney from Canadian.

Some years on he decided to find out what he had. He had the hundred and twenty-five bins swept, steel ones now. He washed his head at the yard hydrant, sat down in the door of the first bin and looked up. Red winter wheat came down out of a clear sky and filled the bin behind him. He did the same at each door.

Now you all try yours, he said.

Lily put on her good dress. She boiled one quart of rice and sat down with it at the cattle guard in a lawn chair, with a gold spoon. *Anybody hungry, come on.* They came with bowls and buckets and ice chests. She dipped all day, and the pot was as full at dark as at sunup. People who stood close saw a moon in the palm of her right hand and a lily in the palm of her left, and when she slipped her shoes off they saw the same on her feet. The women of that family have held the pot with the left hand and dipped with the right at every church dinner since 1904, and carried the water around.

Win washed his head, took a billfold with a thousand dollars in it and stood on the co-op dock. He paid out to everyone who was behind, and when he looked there was a thousand in it. Jessie sat in the yard with a bushel basket of seed wheat and filled every sack that was held out to her.

Fuller put on a clean shirt. He hooked a one-bottom lister to the old Farmall, pressed his hand in red barn paint on each fender the way his people had marked the mules, and drove into the west quarter. Seven furrows opened behind one share. There were three on his left and three on his right and one in the middle, and each was as wide as the first.

So it was that people in that country got cooked food from that house, and seed, and money, each as much as he had need of.

VI. The Count

Fortune · June 2025

On Wednesday R.L. Ramsey drove in to see the Kansas boy. He stopped at the co-op first. The domino table was going in the back, as it had every morning since he could remember, and among the eight men at it there were two deacons and an elder.

Where are you headed, R.L.?

Out to see Ensz.

Nobody played for a moment.

You, of all people, said Harlan Teel. *You believe a man reaps what he sows. You've got a hundred and twenty-five bins out there that say so. What do you want with him? He never sowed an acre in his life. He goes up and down this country telling his hands that nobody reaps what they sow. I had it from a man in Follett. He stood in a field of another man's wheat and said it right out.*

He's a boy, another said. *He thinks because it all runs through his machine it's all one to him.*

R.L. heard them out and went on.

Ensz was cutting a half section north of town. He stopped the machine and put R.L. in the buddy seat, and they made a round. Then he climbed down and walked him along the combine from front to back, as he did with every new hand. He showed him the reel and the sickle and the feeder house. He showed him the rotor, the concaves, the sieves and the fan, the clean grain going up to the tank and the straw and chaff going out behind. He did not hurry. After that they sat on the header in the shade, and he talked in the same order. He started with giving, since that

was what the man knew. He went from there to keeping your hands clean and your word good, and what comes to a person for that. Then he came to what is wrong with what comes, even the best of it. Last he told him how a thing is set down. It took most of an hour. R.L. had fed that country from his porch for forty years, and he found he had been keeping a count the whole time without knowing he kept it. Somewhere in that hour it stopped. It has not started up since.

When he could talk he told Ensz what they were saying at the domino table.

Ensz thought about it. *I did say that. I said I've cut wheat for seventeen years and never cut a field I planted. I said nobody in that cab ought to act like he grew it.* He got up. *Come here.*

He ran the combine fifty yards into the standing wheat and shut the separator off. He took a square of stiff wire from behind the seat, a foot on a side, and went around to the back and threw it on the ground in the chaff. He got down on his knees. R.L. was seventy-one and got down beside him. Ensz parted the chaff inside the wire with two fingers and counted the kernels lying on the dirt.

Fourteen, he said. *Twenty is a bushel an acre going out the back.* He sat on his heels.

From the county road, all anybody sees of a combine is the chaff. A man can sit in the co-op and tell you whose machine is throwing a dirty cloud. What a machine is losing, you only find like this, on your knees behind it. Hardly anybody does it to his own. He would rather keep running and look over the fence. He turned his head. *Pieter. What's the one about the speck?*

Pieter was twenty-two and from the Free State. He found it on his phone and read it standing in the stubble.

> *Why do you see the speck that is in your brother's eye, but don't consider the beam that is in your own eye?*
>
> *You hypocrite! First remove the beam out of your own eye, and then you can see clearly to remove the speck out of your brother's eye.*
>
> *— Matthew 7:3, 5*

They're only winnowing me, Ensz said. *It's light stuff. It blows off.*

R.L. laughed, which he had not expected to do. *Harlan Teel reneged on me in 1988,* he said, *and turned the trick face down before I could see it. He's had his thumb on that domino for thirty-seven years.*

Ensz started the separator. R.L. asked if he could keep the wire, and Ensz said he had another.

That evening the five of them and Vi carried supper out to the field, and Lily's pot fed the crew with the rest. In the morning she looked out the kitchen window and saw her husband behind the house. He was on his knees in the caliche, where the rams had been at it all night, with the wire square on the ground in front of him, and he was counting.

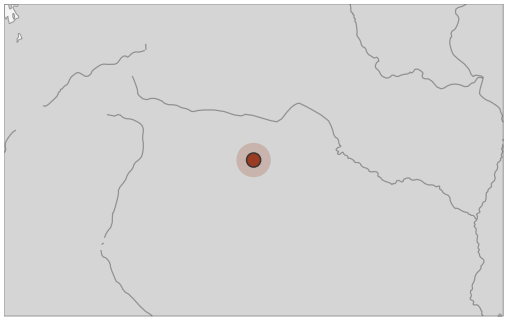
Background

The verse

> *The fault of others is easily perceived, but that of oneself is difficult to perceive; a man winnows his neighbour's faults like chaff, but his own fault he hides, as a cheat hides the bad die from the gambler.*
>
> Dhammapada 252, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The Buddha, traveling in the country of the Aṅguttaras, sees that six people in the town of Bhaddiya are ready to understand him: the rich man Meṇḍaka ("Ram"), his wife Candapadumā ("Moon-Lotus"), their son Dhanañjaya, his wife Sumanā, their small granddaughter Visākhā, and the servant Puṇṇa. The commentary then stops to explain the name. Behind Meṇḍaka's house, golden rams as big as horses butt back to back, and whatever he needs comes out of a ram's mouth when a ball of five-colored thread is removed. Two former lives account for them. In one he was a nephew whose uncle would not let him share in building a Buddha's chamber, so he built an elephant stable opposite it, with a preaching seat resting on golden rams. In the other he was warned of a famine three years off and stored grain in 1,250 granaries, in pits, and even in the plaster of his walls. When all of it was gone, the five who remained on the place each gave their share of the last pound of rice to a solitary Buddha just risen from a week's trance, and each made a wish. His was that his swept granaries would fill when he looked up. His wife's was a pot that never emptied. The son asked for a purse that stayed full, and the daughter-in-law for a basket of seed. The servant asked for seven furrows from one plow, and to keep the same master. The washed pot was found full that evening. Reborn together, the five test

their powers and feed the country. When Meṇḍaka sets out to meet the Buddha, teachers of other sects tell him that he, who believes deeds have results, is going to a man who denies it. He goes anyway, and afterward repeats what they said; the verse is the Buddha's reply. Read the full commentary story. The granddaughter grew up to be Visākhā, the Buddha's chief laywoman.



Fortune (fictional), Ochiltree County, Texas

Ochiltree County, the Dust Bowl, and the harvest run

Ochiltree County lies on the flat top edge of the Texas Panhandle. Stock farming gave way to wheat there after 1900, and by 1930 the county had almost 210,000 acres in it; the Santa Fe reached the new town of Perryton in 1919. The summer of 1931 brought the southern plains a record crop into a collapsed market. Wheat sold for about a quarter a bushel, less than it cost to raise, the elevators filled, and grain was piled on the ground. Then the rain stopped. In the Dust Bowl years that followed, the government bought and destroyed starving cattle, families ate cornbread and beans, and by 1940 the county's wheat acreage had fallen by two thirds. The worst single storm came on Black Sunday, April 14, 1935. It had been a clear day. In the afternoon a wall of dust rolled south across the Oklahoma and Texas panhandles behind flocks of fleeing birds, and turned the day to night. Fortune, the Ramseys, Mr. Krause and the man from the mesa are invented.

Custom harvesters, or cutters, own their combines and follow the ripening wheat north each year, starting in Texas in May and working through Oklahoma, Kansas and the Dakotas toward Canada, cutting for the same farms season after season. The trade grew up during the Second World War and has passed down in families since. Many of the hands now are seasonal workers from abroad, a good number of them from South Africa. Checking a combine's loss is real practice, taught by every state extension service: stop the machine, lay a one-foot square on the ground behind it, and count. About twenty kernels of wheat to the square foot means a bushel an acre left in the field. Forty-two, the domino game of Texas, is played with partners and tricks, and a player who fails to follow suit has reneged. The Ensz crew is invented.

After the story of the rich man Meṇḍaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 252). The original. Scripture from the World English Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

18.11

Best Construction

> *...but defend him, speak well of him, and put the best construction on everything.*
> *— Luther's Small Catechism, the Eighth Commandment*

The way I got it, on Larkspur Circle.

I. The Clipboard

Larkspur Circle, south Lincoln, Nebraska · 1997

Larkspur Circle was nine houses around a bulb of concrete, split-entries and two-stories put up in 1978, and every front yard had a silver maple or a green ash that had gone in as a whip tied to a stake and now stood higher than the roof. The Larkspur Hills Homeowners Association had covenants, twenty-two pages of them, on file with the Lancaster County Register of Deeds. Since 1994 it had also had a Compliance Committee, which was Gordon Ulmer.

He was fifty-six and an internal auditor for one of the insurance companies downtown. Saturday mornings he walked the circle and the two streets that fed it with a clipboard, and he was never wrong. People found that the hard part. Article VI said trash containers were to be stored out of view from the street, and you could see the Novaks' can beside their garage. Article IX allowed one basketball goal to a lot, on a permanent black pole, and the Hansens had the kind on wheels. Fences were to be stained cedar tone. The Sorensens' was nearer redwood, and Gordon carried a paint chip to hold against it. He noted how a man edged his walk, and which way the Beckers' boat sat on its trailer, and that Denny Kratky mowed with his shirt off. In 1996 he wrote up the Larsons for an eighteen-inch satellite dish, and Larson came to the annual meeting with a

printout showing that the federal government had that very fall made it unlawful for an association to forbid a dish under a meter across. Gordon read the printout through twice. He did not forgive the Larsons or the FCC.

Article XI prohibited clotheslines and the outdoor drying of laundry. Gordon would tell whoever was nearest how this one kept his cans and how that one hung out her wash.

I am not saying a thing that isn't in the document, he would say, and that was so.

Marv Hagedorn lived at the back of the bulb, at number 7. He was fifty-three and had Hagedorn Heating & Air, two vans and a nephew, and for a good many years he had taken the seventh-grade Sunday school at Good Shepherd Lutheran. Between the vans and the church he had been in most of the basements on Larkspur Circle and heard most of its children say the commandments. He did not talk a great deal. Gordon had written him up twice under Article VIII, commercial vehicle with signage parked overnight, and Marv had moved the van both times.

II. Rifle Shots

October 25 to 29

It rained all that Friday and Saturday. Sometime Saturday evening, while the Kansas game was on the radio from Lawrence, the rain went over to snow. It was thirty-three degrees and the leaves were still on the trees. By midnight the power was out, and people on the circle stood at their front windows in the dark and listened. A limb would let go with a crack like a deer rifle, and then came the long tearing and the thump. Then another would go, two yards over. It kept on until daylight. By Sunday noon there were thirteen inches on the ground, twice the most Lincoln had ever had in an October, and not a whole tree was left on Larkspur Circle. The Beckers' ash lay across their Suburban.

The lights stayed off eight days out there. School was called off, and people managed.

Denny Kratky had a generator from his deer camp. Marv went down the circle basement by basement with a flashlight in his teeth and wired a cord and plug onto every furnace, so that each could run an hour off Denny's machine, by turns, around the clock. Orange cords lay across three lawns and the common sidewalk. Marv would take nothing for it, and while he was down there he looked each furnace over, since that was his habit. The Hansens cooked for whoever came on a camp stove on their front stoop. Everybody dragged brush to the curb until the curb was a hedge six feet high the whole way round the bulb. The Beckers nailed a blue tarp over the hole in their roof. On Tuesday the sun came out, and Carol Novak, with three children home and no dryer, strung a rope between her deck posts and hung up everything they owned, down to the underwear.

On Wednesday morning each of them found a yellow sheet folded into the storm door. Gordon's printer was down, so he had done them by hand in block capitals. Brush at curb more than twenty-four hours ahead of a scheduled collection, Article VI. Unapproved temporary roof covering, Article IV. Electrical cords across common sidewalk. Open-flame cooking forward of the building line. The Novaks had Article XI, and under REMARKS he had put *undergarments visible from street.* Marv had Article VIII again, six nights.

There were eleven notices. Every one of them was correct.

III. What Does This Mean

The Novaks' basement · Wednesday night

THE NOVAKS HAD THE GENERATOR FROM SEVEN TO EIGHT. Marv was on his knees at their furnace with the access panel off, and Kyle Novak, who was thirteen, sat on the basement stairs in his coat with a flashlight and his confirmation folder, because the basement was where the heat would be. Carol came down with her yellow sheet. Denny Kratky and Paul Becker came down behind her with theirs, and the three of them stood at Marv's back and all talked at once. Gordon had done this. Gordon had said that. In the middle of a disaster, Marv. Underwear.

Marv heard them out and went on with what he was doing. When they had run down he spoke without turning around.

Kyle. What have you got for memory work?

The Eighth.

Stand up and say it.

Kyle had sat under Marv in the seventh grade and knew there was no use arguing. He stood up on the stairs and said it to the furnace.

> *Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor.*
>
> *What does this mean? We should fear and love God that we may not deceitfully belie, betray, slander, nor defame our neighbor, but defend him, speak well of him, and put the best construction on everything.*
>
> *— Luther's Small Catechism*

Pastor give you the long one too?

He had. It was four stapled sheets with a paragraph marked in pen.

Read what he marked.

Kyle held the flashlight on it.

> *For there is a great difference between these two things, judging sin and knowing sin. You may indeed know it, but you are not to judge it. I can indeed see and hear that my neighbor sins, but I have no command to report it to others. Now, if I rush in, judging and passing sentence, I fall into a sin which is greater than his.*
>
> *— Luther's Large Catechism*

Marv set the panel back and sat on his heels.

Is he wrong? About any one of them?

Nobody said he was.

Somebody has to carry the clipboard. I look for what's wrong for a living. I have shut the heat off on a widow in January because her exchanger was cracked, and she stood there and cried, and I shut it off. A man who does his job and tells you to do yours hasn't done you any harm.

He wiped his hands down his coveralls.

But a fellow can get so he likes it. I've had them work for me. They'd come up out of a basement pleased. That one goes looking, and he tells it around, and he never gets one bit better at anything, and I'll tell you why. It's a cracked exchanger. The bad air comes up through his own registers a little at a time, the whole while he's got his eye on your yard. It hasn't any smell. He's the last to know.

He let that stand a moment.

Now. Has any of you said a word of this to Gordon? Or only to me?

Denny looked at his yellow sheet. Carol looked at her son, who had heard her on the subject of Gordon Ulmer all afternoon and was now reading the furnace label with great attention.

Marv plugged in the cord. The blower came up, and the first warm air in that house since Saturday night came out of the register over their heads, and all five of them stood under it and said nothing.

Go on, Kyle, Marv said. *The Ninth.*

IV. The Mirror

Number 4 · Thursday, November 6

THE LIGHTS CAME BACK ON THE THIRD. GORDON'S CLEAN-AND-check fell on the first Thursday of November, as it had for eleven years, and he saw no reason to move it. His own silver maple had split to the ground the first night and still lay across his front walk. He had been busy.

On the basement stairs he mentioned that it had been six nights with the van, and Marv said he knew, he had read it.

Gordon stayed down to watch. He liked to see a thing done in order, and Marv did it in order: the burners out and brushed, the flue, the filter, each reading written on the ticket as he took it.

You write it all down, Gordon said. From him that was praise.

I write it down so whoever comes next year knows where to look. I don't know another reason to.

Marv went into the heat exchanger last, with the flashlight and the little round mirror on its wand. He was in there some time. Then he backed out and held the mirror and the light up to Gordon.

Look for yourself. Left side, second cell, up top. Get the light under it.

Gordon got down on one knee on his own basement floor. It took him a while to find the angle. Then it was there in the glass, a dark line as long as a finger with rust along both lips.

How long?

Two winters. Could be three.

You were here every one of those years.

I was. It opens hot and shuts cold. You catch it the year you catch it.

Marv turned off the gas cock. He took a red tag from his shirt pocket and filled in every line of it, the date, the address, the defect, his license number, and wired it to the valve. Gordon read it through twice. He was still on one knee, with the mirror in his hand, looking up into his own furnace, when Marv went out to the van to call in the order.

It was to freeze hard that night. By dark there were four electric heaters on Gordon Ulmer's front step, each with its owner's name on a strip of masking tape, and nobody had rung the bell. The one from the Novaks had an orange cord coiled on top of it, in case he came up short.

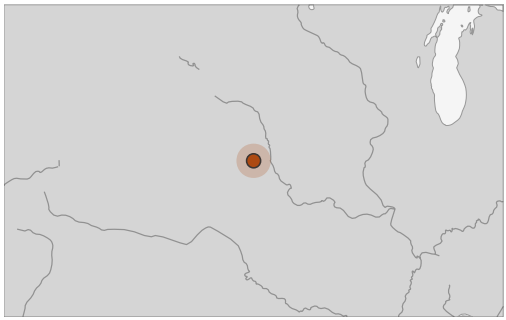
Background

The verse

> *If a man looks after the faults of others, and is always inclined to be offended, his own passions will grow, and he is far from the destruction of passions.*
>
> Dhammapada 253, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest. A monk whose name means "Fault-Finder" goes about remarking on the others: this one puts on his under-robe so, that one his upper robe so. The monks report him to the Buddha. The Buddha first makes a distinction. One who keeps strictly to his duty and admonishes others to do the same is no fault-finder. But one who looks for flaws because he is minded to find them, and goes about talking of them, reaches none of the higher attainments; what

the tradition calls the *āsavas*, the inflowing pollutants, only increase in him. Then he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.



Lincoln, Nebraska

Lincoln, October 1997

On the night of October 25–26, 1997, heavy wet snow fell on eastern Nebraska while the trees were still in full leaf. Lincoln measured 13.2 inches, double its previous record for the whole month of October. Limbs came down all night across the city; at the height of the storm more than 30,000 of Lincoln's 105,000 homes were without power, public schools and the university closed, and the last customers were not reconnected until November 3. Larkspur Circle, its association and its people are invented. The rule Mr. Larson brought to the meeting is real: under the Telecommunications Act of 1996 the Federal Communications Commission barred homeowner associations from prohibiting satellite dishes a meter or less across, effective that October. A cracked heat exchanger in a gas furnace can let combustion gases, including carbon monoxide, into the air a house breathes, and a serviceman who finds one shuts the furnace off and tags it.

Martin Luther wrote both of his catechisms in 1529, the Small Catechism for households and children and the Large Catechism for pastors and teachers. Generations of American Lutheran confirmands learned the Small Catechism's explanations by heart, each beginning "What does this mean?" The wording Kyle recites is the English text of 1912, long used among Midwestern Lutherans. The longer passage is from the Large Catechism in the translation of F. Bente and W. H. T. Dau (1921). Luther goes on, a few lines later, to except those whose office it is to look: a judge, a parent, a pastor, or "a physician who is sometimes compelled to examine and handle the patient."

After the story of the elder Ujjhānasaññī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 253). The original. Scripture from Luther's Small Catechism (the English text of 1912) and Large Catechism (tr. F. Bente and W. H. T. Dau, 1921). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

18.12

Hawk Weather

> *If you are looking for perfect safety, you will do well to sit on a fence and watch the birds; but if you really wish to learn, you must mount a machine and become acquainted with its tricks by actual trial.*
> — *Wilbur Wright, Some Aeronautical Experiments (1901)*

So hab ich's gheert, under the Blue Mountain.

I. The Cabinet

Northern Berks County, Pennsylvania · 1905

Elias Dreibelbis kept school at the Eck for forty-three years, and in all that time no scholar of his told him anything he did not already know. He taught three generations of the township to cipher, to read the English reader and the German Testament, and to stand up when the director came in. He caned the fathers, and later he caned their sons. When he gave up the school in 1894 the directors presented him with a clock, and he went home to his stone house under the mountain and to his birds.

There were four hundred and twelve of them, in glass-fronted cases along three walls of the front room. He had shot and skinned and mounted every one himself, with arsenic soap and tow and glass eyes that came from Philadelphia by the gross. The hawks were the pride of it. He had sixty-one, from the little sharp-shins no bigger than a pigeon up to a golden eagle with its wings half open over the parlor door, and nearly all of them had come off the rock the township called the Pulpit, on the crest of the Blue Mountain, where every fall the hawks came down the ridge out of the northeast. On a good day they came one behind the other

from breakfast to supper, so low along the face of the mountain that a boy could hit one with a stone. Every farm boy in the township had gone up there with a shotgun at one time or another. Elias had gone up for fifty Septembers. He weighed what he brought down on the scale at the post office, measured the wings with a carpenter's rule, and wrote it in a ledger, and people said he knew more about the hawks of the Blue Mountain than the Lord did, who had only made them.

There were three things he did not know. In the winter of 1891 he wrote them out in his best copybook hand and sent them to three authorities. The first was whether there was a fixed road in the air which the birds of prey kept to in their passage, since they came by the same rock every year. The second was whether a man could learn the flight of birds from the study of them in the hand. The third was whether there was anywhere, high up, a constant and steady wind.

The professor of natural history at Franklin and Marshall wrote back two pages on the wisdom of the Creator's design. *Der Readinger Adler* printed them the next spring among the farm notes, under the heading *Curious Inquiries*, with no answers. The Smithsonian Institution in Washington took two years and then sent a grey paper-covered memoir by the Secretary himself, Professor Langley, called *The Internal Work of the Wind*, with a printed slip. Elias read as far as the eighth page, decided that Professor Langley had not understood the question, marked his place with the slip, and put the memoir in the drawer under the eagle.

He did not ask Irvin Moyer. Irvin Moyer had sat in the third row at the Eck from 1878 to 1885 and been kept in at recess for drawing hawks in the margins of his arithmetic. He was a carpenter now, thirty-three years old and unmarried, who kept house with his sister Sallie on the Moyer place at the foot of the mountain. For three summers he had been jumping off the mountain on wings.

II. The First of Everything

The Moyer place · 1904–1905

He had built the first pair from a drawing in a Chicago engineering journal: two wings of bleached muslin, one above the other, on frames of spruce from the lumberyard at Hamburg, braced with piano wire and varnished till they rang when you flicked them. He hung between them by his armpits, ran down the high pasture into the wind, and was lifted. The first summer he went forty feet and broke two ribs, his own and the machine's. The second summer he went across the whole pasture and over the rail fence at the bottom, and the Reformed pastor preached on the tower of Babel, and the Lutheran pastor, who had a son, did not. Men drove out from Kempton on Sunday afternoons to sit on the fence and watch him, the way they would have watched a man try to ride a bull.

Then there was the day in October of 1904 that Jonas Dreibelbis told about for the rest of his life. The wind had come around northwest in the night, cold, the kind of wind the old men called hawk weather, and Jonas was up in the high pasture with the Moyers' hired boy when Irvin ran off the top of it. He did not come down. He went out over the chestnuts along the face of the mountain, the way the hawks went, and the wind coming up the mountain held him there. Jonas said a broad-wing passed under him and two red-tails passed over, and none of the three paid him any more mind than they paid the trees. The boy ran down to the house for Sallie, and she came up the lane with flour to her elbows, and he was still up. He stayed up long enough for Jonas to say the Lord's Prayer three times through, slowly, in German. Then he came down in the same pasture he had started from, on his feet, and folded the wings, and went in to his supper.

Nobody outside the township believed it. Inside the township, people believed it the way they believed in the hex doctor at Lenhartsville, which is to say they did not discuss it in front of the pastors.

Jonas was Elias's younger brother by six years. He had stopped at the Fourth Reader and farmed the home place and given things away all his

life, and in the summer of 1905 he took it into his head to carry the first of everything up to the Moyers' barn floor, where Irvin built his wings. He brought the first asparagus in April, and the first rhubarb, and the first strawberries in a split basket. He brought peas, and cherries off the big tree by the springhouse, and new potatoes, and the first ears of sweet corn, and the first peaches, and a peck of Early Harvest apples in August. That was nine times. Each time he stopped at the stone house on the way and said, *Come along up, Elias. He'll show you.*

Each time Elias said, *I don't go to school to my own scholars.*

At the end of August Irvin took the typhoid. Two others had it on that road already, and people blamed the Moyer well. The doctor drove out from Kempton every second day and ordered milk, and broth, and the patient sponged with cold water whenever the fever climbed. Cold water in August meant ice, and the Moyers had no icehouse. Elias had one, because a man who mounts birds needs ice the way a miller needs water. Jonas came to him for it with his hat in his hand.

Elias said nothing at all. But that night his hired man drove down to the Moyer place with a block of ice packed in sawdust in the back of the spring wagon, and every morning after that there was another. It was the only thing Elias gave. Jonas said afterward that it was the reason he got there at all, even at the last.

III. The Curtain

The Moyer place · September 1905

In the third week the doctor found blood. He told Sallie at the kitchen table that it would be days, and he told the postmaster at Kempton the same thing in fewer words, and by evening it was all through the township.

Elias heard it at the post office and walked home and sat down in the front room among the cases. The glass eyes looked at him. He thought: I asked a professor, and a newspaper, and the Government of the United States. I never asked him because I had kept him in at recess. If he dies before I ask him I will be sorry for the rest of my life, which is not going

to be long either. He took a clean sheet of paper and wrote the three questions out again, in the same words he had used in 1891, and folded it in his breast pocket, and put on his coat.

The wind had come around in the night. It was cold for September, the sky scrubbed blue, and as he crossed the stubble toward the Moyer place he saw them going over the ridge already, broad-wings, high up and many, turning in great slow kettles over the gap and then sliding off southwest one after the other as if somebody were pouring them.

Sallie Moyer met him at the kitchen door. She was a big plain woman a little older than her brother, and she had not slept in a bed for nine nights.

He's tired, Schoolmaster. He can't have company.

I won't keep him. I have three questions.

Not today.

I won't keep him long.

Elias, she said, and it was the first time in her life she had called him by his given name, *you had three summers. Go home.*

Then Irvin's voice came out of the downstairs bedroom, not loud. *Sallie. Let the schoolmaster in. He's come a long way.* It was half a mile.

The door of the bedroom had been taken off its hinges for the air and a curtain hung there instead, against the flies. When Elias lifted it he felt that it was stiff, and saw that it was wing muslin with the varnish still on it, patched in one corner where something had torn. He went in under it and sat down on the chair at the foot of the bed.

IV. Three Questions

The same morning

Irvin lay with his hands outside the quilt. The fever had taken the flesh off him, and his hair was cut short for it, so that he looked about fifteen, about the age he had been when he left the Eck. The window was open on the mountain. He did not seem to be in any pain, or if he was it was somewhere a long way off, and his face was quiet the way a pond is quiet in the morning before anything has landed on it.

You have a paper, he said.

Elias unfolded it and read the first question as he had written it fourteen years before, in the voice he had used for dictation. *Whether there is a fixed road or path in the air, which the birds of prey keep to in their passage.* He looked up. *They come by the Pulpit every year. The same rock. There must be a road.*

Irvin turned his head on the pillow toward the window. A broad-wing was coming along the face of the mountain, low, below the crest, its wings held flat and still.

There goes one. Watch where he goes.

They watched it slide past the window frame and out of sight down the ridge.

Now show me where he went.

Elias looked at the air over the chestnuts. It was blue and empty and exactly like the rest of the sky.

There's no track, Irvin said. *There's the mountain, and the wind going up it like water going up the face of a dam. They come where the wind comes up. Next year it comes up a little someplace else, and so do they. Nobody made a road up there, Schoolmaster. You can't follow anybody.*

Elias read the second question. *Whether a man may learn the flight of birds from the study of them in the hand.* He did not wait. *I have sixty-one hawks. I have weighed every one and measured every one. I have it all in the ledger, to the quarter inch.*

Sallie, said Irvin, *get the grey book off the clock shelf.*

She brought it in without a word: a thin pamphlet from the Smithsonian, a reprint of an address some bicycle maker from Ohio had given to the engineers in Chicago, with one corner turned down. Irvin nodded at Elias to read, and Elias read it aloud, because he had never in his life been handed a book and not read it aloud.

> *Now, there are two ways of learning to ride a fractious horse: One is to get on him and learn by actual practice how each motion and trick may be best met; the other is to sit on a fence and watch the beast a while, and then retire to the house and at leisure figure out the best way of overcoming his jumps and kicks. The latter system is the safest, but the former, on the whole, turns out the larger proportion of good riders. It is very much the same in learning to ride a flying machine; if you are looking for perfect safety, you will do well to sit on a fence and watch the birds; but if you really wish to learn, you must mount a machine and become acquainted with its tricks by actual trial.*
>
> *— Wilbur Wright, Some Aeronautical Experiments (1901)*

I didn't sit on any fence, said Elias. *I had them in my hands.*

You had them after they quit, Irvin said, gently enough. *Every one of them. All you know about how they fly, you found out when they were done flying.*

Elias sat with that. Behind the curtain Sallie was pumping water at the sink, and the pump handle squealed, and stopped.

He had written more on the back of the paper. Over fourteen years the three questions had grown footnotes: objections, references to Audubon and to Wilson, the weights of particular birds, a page of argument against a correspondent of the *Adler* who held that hawks soared by some lightness in their bones. He turned the paper over and looked at all of it and turned it back.

The third, he said. *Whether there is anywhere, high up, a constant and steady wind. If a man could get up into it—*

Irvin smiled for the first time.

You have that one in your own house. In the drawer under the eagle.

Elias stared at him.

Jonas brought it up in May with the rhubarb. He put it back after. Your slip was in at page eight. He lifted one hand a little off the quilt, toward the doorway. *Turn around.*

Elias turned on the chair. On the inside of the curtain he had come in under, on the muslin of what had been the lower wing, someone had copied out a passage in carpenter's pencil, in the round slanted copybook

hand that Elias himself had taught at the Eck for forty-three years, so that the man flying would have it over his head.

> *If, on the one hand, owing to the weight and inertia of the anemometer, this is far from doing justice to the actual irregularities of the wind; on the other, it equally shows that the wind was far from being a body of even approximate uniformity of motion, and that, even when considered in quite small sections, the motion was found to be irregular almost beyond conception, — certainly beyond anticipation; for this record is not selected to represent an extraordinary breeze, but the normal movement of an ordinary one.*
>
> *— S. P. Langley, The Internal Work of the Wind (Smithsonian Institution, 1893), page 8*

Page eight, said Irvin. *Nothing up there holds still. Not for one second. That's what holds you up.*

Out past the window the broad-wings kept coming down the ridge, one and then another, and none of them was where the last one had been.

Sallie came in with a basin and stood with it. Her face was working. Irvin looked at her and then at the old man on the chair, and he did not look like somebody who was going to die by the end of the week, or like somebody who was not. He looked like somebody watching weather.

Sallie, the schoolmaster's cold. Give him some coffee before he goes.

Elias folded the paper with all its footnotes and put it away. At the curtain he stopped with the stiff muslin in his hand, and asked the thing he had not written down.

Irvin. Would you teach me?

Go up on the Pulpit, Irvin said, *next time it blows northwest. Leave the gun home.*

V. The Pulpit

The Blue Mountain · October 1905

Irvin Moyer died two nights later, toward morning, with Sallie asleep in the chair, so that nobody heard him go. They buried him from the union church on the Saturday, and the Reformed pastor and the Lutheran pastor both spoke, which had not happened since the Civil War. Jonas carried. Elias stood at the back with his hat in his hands and did not sing. The wind that day was out of the south and soft, and nothing came down the ridge at all.

It came around northwest again on the third of October.

Elias was seventy-six years old. It took him the whole of the morning to climb the mountain by the old charcoal road, resting on stumps, and he went up for the first time in fifty-one autumns with nothing in his hands. When he came out onto the Pulpit at noon the wind was pouring up the north face so hard that it lifted the skirts of his coat and held them out behind him, and the hawks were coming.

They came down the ridge out of the northeast, red-tails mostly by then, one, and then nothing, and then three. He stood on the rock where he had stood with a gun for half a century and watched them come. One came along the face below the crest at the height of his own head, so close that he could see the wind ruffle the small feathers at its shoulders, and see it shift, hardly at all, a finger's width, to each breath of air it met. It turned its head and looked at him going by, the way a scholar looks at the master from the third row, and slid on down the mountain, and was gone.

He looked at the place where it had been. It was the same as all the rest of the air.

After a while he lifted his right hand into the wind, flat, the palm turned down, and felt it pushed up from underneath, irregularly, a little and then more and then less, never once the same. He kept it there. Jonas, who came up at four o'clock to look for him, found him standing on the rock in that way with the hawks going past him, his arm up, like a scholar who knows the answer and is waiting to be called on.

Background

The verses

> *There is no path through the air, a man is not a Samana by outward acts. The world delights in vanity, the Tathagatas (the Buddhas) are free from vanity.*
>
> Dhammapada 254, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *There is no path through the air, a man is not a Samana by outward acts. No creatures are eternal; but the awakened (Buddha) are never shaken.*
>
> Dhammapada 255, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary sets this story at the Buddha's deathbed in the sal grove at Kusinārā, drawing on the account of his last days in the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta. Long ago, it says, the wanderer Subhadda's younger brother gave alms of the first fruits of a crop nine times while Subhadda refused, giving only at the very end; so Subhadda came to the Buddha only at the very end too. He had put three doubts to the old teachers but never to the Buddha, whom he thought of as a youngster. Hearing that the Buddha was dying, he came to ask them. Ānanda tried to turn him away, but the Buddha told Ānanda to let him in, and Subhadda sat at the foot of the bed and asked: is there a path through the air, is there a true ascetic outside the teaching, are conditioned things constant? The Buddha answered with these two verses. Read the full commentary story.

Below the Blue Mountain, Berks County, Pennsylvania

The Blue Mountain, 1905

The Blue Mountain runs about 150 miles across eastern Pennsylvania from the Delaware Water Gap, continuing in New Jersey as Kittatinny Mountain, and the Schuylkill River cuts through it just north of Hamburg. Each fall thousands of hawks, eagles and falcons migrate along it, broad-winged hawks peaking in September and red-tails later, and the stretch now protected as Hawk Mountain Sanctuary was for

generations a popular place to shoot them, for sport or to protect poultry, until Rosalie Edge leased the land in 1934 and hired wardens to keep the gunners away. The broad-winged hawks travel in great soaring flocks called kettles. The farm families below the ridge were Pennsylvania Dutch, most of them Lutheran or Reformed "church people," who often shared one union church between the two congregations.

By 1905 gliding was a small international hobby. Otto Lilienthal made over 2,000 glides in Germany before a crash killed him in August 1896, and that summer Octave Chanute and his helpers tested gliders in the dunes of Lake Michigan, among them the strut-and-wire biplane the Wright brothers later called the "double-decker." Wilbur Wright described their own glider trials to the Western Society of Engineers in Chicago in September 1901, and the Smithsonian reprinted the address in its annual report for 1902. Its Secretary, Samuel Pierpont Langley, had argued in *The Internal Work of the Wind* (1893) that the wind is never uniform, and that a soaring bird might be sustained by its constant pulsations; his own engine-driven Aerodrome fell into the Potomac twice in the autumn of 1903. Irvin Moyer, Elias and the Pulpit's township are fictional.

After the story of the wanderer Subhadda from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 254–255). The original. Scripture from Wilbur Wright, *Some Aeronautical Experiments* (1901), and S. P. Langley, *The Internal Work of the Wind* (1893). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 19

The Just

19.1

Not of Record

> *For his duty is, not to make a present of justice, but to give judgment.*
> *— Plato, Apology, tr. Jowett*

As it was given to me, on the square at Pruett.

I. The Supper

Pruett, Kinney County, Illinois · a Tuesday in October 1958

Harold Stites kept the books at the Farmers Grain elevator and had kept them fourteen years without an erasure the auditor could find. His wife had signed the two of them up for Great Books at the library in September. She came to the first meeting, on the Declaration of Independence, and said on the way home that she had not known people could talk for two hours about the word *self-evident*. After that Harold went alone.

The group met every other Tuesday at half past seven in the basement room of the Carnegie library, under the steam pipes. There were eleven of them, and each had the set of nine paper-covered books in a cardboard case that came down from the Foundation in Chicago. The second reading was Plato, the *Apology*. Harold had read it twice at the scale-house desk between trucks. It was bean harvest and the trucks came steadily, and he kept his place with a blank grain ticket.

The E.U.B. church on North Chestnut gave its harvest supper that same Tuesday, chicken and noodles over mashed potatoes, a dollar a plate and nothing said if you did not have the dollar. Five of the Great Books people ate there together at the end of a long table. There was Harold. There was Mrs. Rademacher, whose husband had the Buick

agency, and Walt Ihnen, who adjusted hail and fire claims for the farm mutual. There was Mr. Venable, who had taught Latin at the high school until the board stopped offering it, and Donna Lutz, a senior, who came because Mr. Venable had told her it would count for something at Urbana. The church women would not let them go without pie. It was ten past seven when they started south toward the library with their books inside their coats, and the rain caught them on the square.

It came all at once, the way it will in October after a warm day, loud on the roofs of the parked cars. The library was on the far side of the square. The courthouse stood in the middle of it with its east door open and a light on in the hall, and they ran for that.

II. The Squire's Room

The courthouse, ground floor · the same evening

The voices came from the end of the east hall. The circuit court sat upstairs, in daylight, under a pressed-tin ceiling, and the county liked to say that Lincoln had tried cases on that ground when the Eighth Circuit came through. The room downstairs was one the supervisors rented for eight dollars a month to Orrin Dace, justice of the peace for Pruett Township. He had been elected three times. By day he kept a notary and collection office over the dime store. On Tuesday nights he held court, and people called him Squire.

Two benches for the public stood along the back wall with nobody on them. The five sat down to wait out the rain. Mrs. Rademacher shook her scarf. Donna Lutz opened her Plato.

The Squire sat at an oak table with his docket book and a brass inkwell he had no use for, since he wrote with a ballpoint. At a smaller table sat Vern Tolle, who worked for Burkett's Furniture and Appliance, with a stack of contracts and a stack of file cards. Down the side wall, on folding chairs, sat fourteen or fifteen people in work clothes and church clothes. Each of them held the paper the constable had brought to the door.

Burkett against Doyle Capps, the Squire said.

A man stood up. Harold knew him by sight. He hauled corn to the elevator for his father-in-law in the fall, and the rest of the year he built tractors in Peoria, or had until March.

Vern Tolle read from a card. One Philco television, twenty-one inch, console. Contract price two hundred sixty-nine ninety-five. Payments missed, August and September. Balance owing, thirty-one dollars. The plaintiff asked possession of the set.

That right, Doyle?

I'm behind, Capps said. *I been laid off since March. I paid the August one, though. I paid it at the store, to the girl. I've got the*

You can take that up with Mr. Burkett. Judgment for the plaintiff, possession and costs. The Squire wrote in the book. *Costs are seven-eighty. The constable will be out tonight. Burkett against Pease.*

Harold looked at the clock over the door when Mrs. Pease stood up and again when she sat down. It had taken a minute and a half. A wringer washer, ninety dollars paid on a hundred and nineteen, a husband buried in June. She had begun to tell what the man at the store had promised her at the funeral, and she got as far as his name.

Harold was a bookkeeper and could not sit in a room where figures were read aloud without keeping them. He took the grain ticket out of his Plato and wrote on the back. By the time the rain let up he had eleven names down the left side, and beside each one what had been paid in and what was owed. Eleven cases in thirty-eight minutes. Eleven judgments for the plaintiff. Nobody had been asked a second question. Through the hall window that gave on the alley he could see Burkett's truck with its motor running and the constable in the cab beside the driver.

At ten minutes to eight the Squire said they would take five. Vern Tolle went up to the oak table and counted bills onto the blotter, so much a case, the filing fees. That much was the law. A justice drew no salary. He lived on his fees, and his fees came from whoever brought him the business. Then Tolle took a ten out of his shirt pocket, folded once, lifted the brass inkwell, and set it down again on top of the bill. The Squire was looking at his docket. He did not look up, and he said nothing. A moment

later he squared the book on the table, and there was nothing under the inkwell.

Walt Ihnen had seen it too. Harold could tell by how still he sat.

I voted for that man, Mrs. Rademacher said on the courthouse steps. *Twice. Clarence put his card in the showroom window.*

I had always supposed, Mr. Venable said, and left it there. Halfway across the wet street he said there was a fable, he could not think where he had it from, some man who had worked on a railroad out West, about a fox asked to divide a fish between two otters. The fox gave one the head and one the tail and kept the middle for the court.

III. The Second Reading

The Carnegie library, basement room · eight o'clock

Miss Verna Coyle had started without them. She was the official reporter of the circuit court and had been for twenty-two years, under three judges. She led the Great Books the way the Foundation trained its leaders to. The leader asks questions. She does not answer them, and she does not say what she thinks. People who had known Verna Coyle since grade school said the training could not have cost her much effort.

She looked at the five wet coats and then at the clock, and asked the only question she asked that night that was not about Plato.

Where have you been?

They told her, all five at once, and then Harold alone, from his ticket. She listened the way she listened upstairs, except that her hands lay still. When he was through she asked three things.

How long did each one take?

A minute and a half. Two.

Did the Squire ask any of them what they had to say?

He asked was it right. Then he stopped them.

Did anybody take it down?

Nobody had. A justice's court was not a court of record. There was the docket book, with the name and the judgment and the costs, and that was all there would ever be of Doyle Capps and his August payment.

Miss Coyle opened her paper Plato. *Mr. Stites, will you read where Socrates has been found guilty and speaks about the time.*

> *...the time has been too short; if there were a law at Athens, as there is in other cities, that a capital cause should not be decided in one day, then I believe that I should have convinced you. But I cannot in a moment refute great slanders...*
>
> *— Plato, Apology, tr. Jowett*

Why does he say the time was too short?

Nobody answered right away, which was allowed. Donna Lutz said it was because they had it settled before he opened his mouth. Walt Ihnen said you could not adjust a hail claim from the road. You had to walk out into the man's field, and then, if you were any good, you walked his neighbor's.

And where he speaks of what a judge is for. Mrs. Rademacher.

> *For his duty is, not to make a present of justice, but to give judgment; and he has sworn that he will judge according to the laws, and not according to his own good pleasure...*
>
> *— Plato, Apology, tr. Jowett*

What is a present of justice? Miss Coyle asked.

A ten-dollar bill under an inkwell, Walt said.

Is it only that?

Harold looked at his ticket. He said that as near as he could figure, the present had been made before the ten ever came out of the pocket. It was made when the man said *I've got the* and did not get to say what he had.

It was the best thing he said all that year, and Miss Coyle did not tell him so. She went against her training once that night, at the end, when they were stacking the chairs. She said that for twenty-two years the county had paid her to do one thing, which was to get down what both

sides said, all of it, no faster than they said it. She said she had noticed that a judge hears a case differently when he knows it is going down. Then she asked Mr. Venable to get the lights.

IV. The Tape

The Squire's room · the Tuesday following, and after

The next Tuesday was not a Great Books night. Harold went to the courthouse anyway. Walt Ihnen was on the back bench ahead of him, and Mrs. Rademacher, and Donna Lutz with her mother.

At seven Miss Coyle came down the east hall carrying her Stenotype in its case. She stood the tripod beside the radiator, where she could see the Squire's mouth and the folding chairs both. She fed in a fresh pack of paper and sat down with her fingers on the keys.

The Squire looked at her for some time. *Verna. This is not a court of record.*

No, she said.

Who is paying you?

Nobody.

He could not think of a statute against it, and the room was public. *Burkett against Emery,* he said. The machine made its small sound, hardly more than a knuckle on a table, and the paper moved up one line.

It moved up a line for everything. It moved when Vern Tolle read his card and when the Squire said *That right?* and when Mr. Emery said he was behind. When Mr. Emery stopped, it stopped, and the whole room could hear it waiting. The Squire heard it.

Go on, he said. *If you have something to say, say it.*

Emery said the freezer had quit in July with half a hog in it and the store never sent anybody, and that was when he quit paying. The machine took that down. The Squire asked Vern Tolle whether it was so. Vern Tolle did not have a card for it.

They got through four cases by nine o'clock. One of them the Squire put over two weeks so a woman could bring in her receipts, and nobody in the room could remember him putting a case over for a defendant be-

fore. Burkett's truck stood in the alley a long while with its motor running, and then somebody shut it off.

She came every Tuesday after that. The amendment that would have done away with the squires' courts lost that November, though nearly two of every three who marked the question marked it yes. It passed four years later, and on the first of January 1964 there were no more justices' courts in Illinois. That made better than five years of Tuesdays. Doyle Capps never got his set back. His time to appeal ran out before anyone thought to tell him there was such a thing, and the group took up a collection, which Harold kept the account of.

Nobody ever asked for a transcript. Nobody could have read the tapes but Miss Coyle, since a reporter's notes are in the machine's shorthand with her own short forms laid over it. She folded each night's paper, put a rubber band around it, and wrote the date on the edge in pencil. The courthouse had no place to file the record of a court that kept none. So she carried the packs across the square, and the librarian gave her an empty shelf in the basement room.

Harold counted them once, the winter the squires' courts ended, while he waited for the others to come down the stairs. Two hundred and fifty-one packs, each about the size of a pound of butter, each with its date. He took one down and let out a little of it. Three or four pale purple letters to a line, a line for every stroke, on down the narrow paper. He could not make out one word. He folded it back the way she had and put it in its place.

Background

The verses

> *A man is not just if he carries a matter by violence; no, he who distinguishes both right and wrong, who is learned and leads others, not by violence, but by law and equity, and who is guarded by the law and intelligent, he is called just.*
>
> Dhammapada 256, 257, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest. Bhikkhus coming back through Sāvatthī from their almsround are caught by rain and shelter in a hall of justice, where they watch the ministers take bribes and strip lawful owners of their property. They tell the Buddha, who answers that a man who settles a case in haste (the Pāli *sahasā* means both rashly and by force) does not stand by the Dhamma; the one who weighs both sides and leads others without haste, by what is right, is its guardian. Read the full commentary story.

Pruett (fictional), central Illinois

Downstate Illinois, 1958

Until 1964 the lowest courts in Illinois were those of justices of the peace and police magistrates: elected, usually not lawyers, usually holding another job, and paid by the fees of the cases brought before them. Theirs were not courts of record, so an appeal meant a whole new trial in a higher court. Critics said for decades that a judge who lives on fees leans toward the party who brings him business. A new judicial article that would have folded these courts into the circuit courts went to the voters on November 4, 1958; it drew about 64 percent of the votes cast on the question and still failed to meet the constitutional threshold. A second version passed in 1962 and took effect on January 1, 1964. The Illinois courts tell the story here. Pruett, Kinney County, Squire Dace and his Tuesday docket are invented; the Eighth Judicial Circuit that Lincoln rode as a lawyer in the 1840s and 1850s was real. The year is that of the 1958 recession, when layoffs in the Midwest's factories left many families behind on installment contracts.

The Great Books Foundation was set up in Chicago in 1947 by Robert Maynard Hutchins and Mortimer Adler, and through the 1950s its discussion groups met every other week in public libraries across the country. Lay leaders were trained to ask questions and keep their own opinions out of it. The first-year course of that decade opened with the Declaration of Independence and went on to Plato's *Apology* and *Crito*. The passages here are from Benjamin Jowett's translation. The harvest supper is at a church of the Evangelical United Brethren, a denomination that exis-

ted from 1946 until it merged into the United Methodist Church in 1968. Miss Coyle's machine is the stenotype, which prints a few letters per stroke on a narrow folding tape.

After the story of the ministers of justice from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 256 and 257). The original. Scripture from Plato's *Apology* in the translation of Benjamin Jowett. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

19.2

Hollow Gourd

Hollow gourd mek mos' noise.
— Jamaica Negro Proverbs and Sayings (1910), no. 364

A so mi hear it, by the schoolyard on Fox Street.

I. Sweepings

Westchester Avenue, the Bronx · a Saturday in October 1979

The Saturday after a jam, Winston Brissett and Hector Colón always ate breakfast at the bakery under the el on Westchester Avenue, because Winston's aunt worked the counter and gave them the patties that had split in the oven for a dime apiece. They were fourteen and fifteen. They had been on the mic the night before for the first time in front of more than a hundred people, at the end of the night, when most of the older heads had gone home. Little Winnie and Kid Hex. They had worked out their routine on the roof of Hector's building all summer, trading lines back and forth over a beat Hector kept on a garbage can lid, and the night before it had gone the way it went on the roof, which almost never happened.

They sat at the counter with coco bread and a beef patty each and went over it line by line, the way you go over a ball game.

Six young men came in out of the rain without shutting the door.

Everybody under the el knew who they were. They called themselves the Mighty Six, from Kelly Street, and they went from jam to jam all over the Bronx, the schoolyards and the parks and the P.A.L. gyms, and wherever they went they took the mic. They did not ask for it. They walked up to the table and took it out of whatever hand had it, and talked into it until the DJ gave up or the police came. They were not bad on the

mic. Raheem, who did most of the talking, had a voice like a tenor sax and never once ran out of words. That was the trouble. He never ran out.

All that fall the radio had been playing a record by three men from Jersey nobody had ever seen at a jam, fourteen minutes of rhymes some of which, people said, had come out of a Bronx MC's own notebook. The Mighty Six had taken it hard. They said there were only six real MCs left in the Bronx and they were all of them standing right here.

Raheem saw Winston at the counter.

Little Winnie, he said. *Kid Hex. I heard about you. I heard you were on Lindo's set last night talking like you had something to say.*

Winston's aunt said, *Raheem, you buying something?*

We the only ones nice, Raheem said to the room. *Everybody else is just talking. These little Jamaican boys are taking up the air.*

The counterman had been sweeping behind the display case and had the morning's sweepings in a dustpan, flour and crumbs and cigarette ends and the wet grit that came in on everybody's shoes. One of the Six took it out of his hand the way you would take a plate. Two others caught Winston and Hector from behind by the collars and held them on their stools. Raheem took the dustpan and poured it slowly over Winston's head, and then what was left over Hector's, and set it on the counter and wiped his fingers on a napkin.

Go home and practice, he said, *for about five years.*

Somebody laughed. The Six went out into the rain. The counterman picked up the dustpan and looked at it. Winston's aunt came around the counter with a dish towel and started on Winston's hair, hard, saying things under her breath in the voice she used at home, and he let her, and did not look at Hector, and Hector sat very still with flour in his eyelashes and his patty in his hand.

II. The Boiler Room

Fox Street · that afternoon

Mr. Fitzroy Lindo was the super of a six-story building on Fox Street, one of the few on that block that still had all its windows.

He had come up from Kingston in 1967. In Kingston, people said, he had run a sound in Jones Town that played against the big ones and was never once outplayed, and you could still hear a little of it in the way he lifted a needle. Here he fixed boilers and changed fuses and kept the hallways swept, and on Saturday nights in good weather his son Delroy carried the speaker boxes up the basement steps and out to the schoolyard, and Mr. Lindo plugged his amplifier into the bottom of a lamppost and played.

He did not talk on the mic. Delroy did, a little, and the boys who came around, and lately half the young men in Longwood who could put two lines together. Mr. Lindo stood behind the turntables with a felt hat on and chose records. He chose them the way a man picks fruit, slowly, turning each one in his hands, and then he dropped the needle exactly where the drums came in, and the whole schoolyard went up at once like birds.

The speaker boxes lived in the boiler room. That was where the boys went.

They had washed their hair at Hector's. It did not matter. They came down the basement steps with their hands in their pockets and stood by the boxes and told it to Delroy, who was on the floor rewiring a plug, and Delroy got up with the plug in his hand and went and told his father.

Mr. Lindo was at the bench by the boiler with the tone arm of one of the turntables in a little vise, cleaning the stylus with a brush made of a few hairs. He listened to Delroy. He listened to Winston, who said more than he meant to, and to Hector, who said one sentence in Spanish and stopped. He put the brush down.

On a nail over the bench hung a calabash gourd, dried brown, with a hole cut in the top. His mother had carried water in it, in St. Elizabeth, before any of them were born. He reached up and knocked on it with one knuckle, twice, and it gave back a sound much bigger than itself, hollow, a sound that filled up the boiler room and kept going.

He let it stop.

Hear that? he said. *Nothing in it.*

Then he said the thing his mother used to say, the way she said it, and after it another one, and went back to the stylus.

Hollow gourd mek mos′ noise.

Patient man ride jackass.

— Izett Anderson and Frank Cundall, Jamaica Negro Proverbs and Sayings (1910)

Delroy laughed. Winston did not get it, or not all of it. He got the first part. A man who talks the most is not the one with the most in him. He did not know what the jackass was for. He stood by the boxes with his hands in his pockets and watched Mr. Lindo clean the needle, and the needle was so small, and the hands so careful with it, that after a while he forgot about his hair.

III. The Lamppost

The schoolyard on Fox Street · the next Saturday night

It was the last warm night of the year and three hundred people came. Delroy ran the cable across the sidewalk to the lamppost and taped it down, and the boxes stood at the end of the schoolyard against the fence, two bass bins as tall as Winston, and the amplifier warmed up with its little red light, and Mr. Lindo laid out his crates on a folding table under the streetlamp, where the light was orange and fell on everything the same.

Winston and Hector were on the mic early, when the crowd was still thin. Then the older MCs from Longwood had it, and then Delroy, and the yard filled up and the noise of it rose off the asphalt like heat.

The Mighty Six came in through the gate on the Fox Street side a little after eleven, in a line, and the crowd opened in front of them because it knew them. Raheem walked straight to the table and took the mic out of the hand of the boy who had it.

He talked. He was good. He talked about himself, and the Six, and Kelly Street, and about the Jersey record and the men who made it, and about every fool holding a mic from Mott Haven to Fordham Road, and about little Jamaican boys who ought to be home in bed, and his voice went up and down the yard over the break like a man running his hand

along a fence. The crowd hollered for him. Then it hollered less. He kept going. He did not let the record breathe. Every place in the music where something might have happened, Raheem was there first, talking.

Mr. Lindo let him. He stood behind the turntables in his hat and kept the break going, catching it on one record as it ran out on the other, back and forth, the same eight bars of drums over and over, so that Raheem would never be without something under him.

That was when two of the Six came around behind the table with the schoolyard trash can.

It was a wire can chained to the fence, and they had unhooked it, and it was full of what a schoolyard is full of on a Saturday night, paper cups and chicken bones and bottle caps and the sweepings of a week, and they lifted it up over Mr. Lindo's head and turned it over.

It came down on his hat and his shoulders and onto the folding table and into the open crates. A cup rolled across a record and off. The yard made a sound, all of it at once, and then went quiet in a ring around the table. Delroy was coming over the cable with his face changed. Winston could not move at all.

Mr. Lindo did not stop the record.

He did not look up, or around, or at the two of them standing behind him with the empty can. The break was running out on the left turntable and he caught it on the right, clean, with grit on the backs of his hands, and the drums came in again on the one exactly where they had come in a thousand times, and the yard heard them. He put out one hand flat toward Delroy without turning, and Delroy stopped where he was.

Then he reached over and turned the mic down.

He left it on. Raheem was still talking, and you could hear him, a little, if you were close, a small voice somewhere under the drums. Mr. Lindo let the break go round once more by itself, and then he lifted the needle off the left record and laid it into the right one at a different place, and what came out of the bins was a horn line nobody in that yard had heard before, long and slow, over a bass that you felt in your knees.

The yard went up. It went up like birds. Three hundred people danced on the asphalt in the orange light, and nobody was listening to Raheem

any longer. Nobody had stopped him. He had nothing in him the music did not already have. He stood with the mic in his hand. After a while he put it down on the table, carefully, among the bottle caps.

Mr. Lindo picked a chicken bone off the record on the right turntable without stopping it and dropped it on the ground. He still had not looked at any of them. He did not look angry. He did not look like anything. He looked like a man choosing fruit.

When the record ran out he leaned to Raheem, and Winston, who was close enough by then, heard him. He said it the way you would tell somebody the time.

You have a good voice. Come Tuesday. Help carry the boxes.

IV. Tuesday

Fox Street · Tuesday evening

Raheem did not come Tuesday. He never came. The Mighty Six went on taking mics at other jams for a while, and then, the way crews do, there were four of them, and then nobody could say.

But a boy named Tito, who was the youngest of them and had held Hector by the collar at the bakery, came down the basement steps on Fox Street on Tuesday evening with his hands in his pockets. He stood by the boxes and did not say anything, and Mr. Lindo did not say anything, and after a while Delroy handed him the end of a cable to coil.

The felt hat was on a nail over the bench, next to the gourd. Mr. Lindo had not brushed it. There was still a little grit in the crease of the crown.

Winston and Hector worked on their routine all that winter on Hector's roof, in coats, with the garbage can lid. It got shorter. They started leaving holes in it, places where neither of them said anything and Hector just hit the lid, once, and let it ring, and you could hear the el go by on Westchester Avenue, and then the next line came. In the spring they tried it at the schoolyard. When they got to the first hole and stopped, the whole yard leaned in toward them, waiting, and Winston stood there in the orange light with his mouth shut and his heart going, and let it ring.

Background

The verse

> *A man is not learned because he talks much; he who is patient, free from hatred and fear, he is called learned.*
>
> Dhammapada 258, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The Group of Six (Chabbaggiyā) are the troublemaking monks of the Buddhist monastic code, blamed for the misconduct behind many of its rules. In this short commentary story they go from monastery to monastery and village to village making trouble in the refectories, boasting that they alone are intelligent and wise. One morning, after breakfast in a village, some young monks and novices come back and report that the Six grabbed them from behind and poured sweepings over their heads. The monks tell the Buddha, who says that he does not call a man wise because he talks much, only one who is patient, free from hatred and free from fear. Read the full commentary story, or about the Vinaya, the monastic code so many of whose rules began with something the Six had done.

Longwood, the Bronx, New York

The Bronx, *1979*

Hip hop began in the West and South Bronx in the early 1970s, at parties and outdoor jams where DJs, among them the Jamaican-born DJ Kool Herc, brought the island's sound system culture north and extended the drum breaks of funk records on two turntables. Outdoor jams often ran on power drawn from the base of a lamppost. MCs, at first the DJ's helpers, began rhyming over the breaks, and crews toured the borough's schoolyards, parks and community centers. In September 1979 Sugar Hill Records released the Sugarhill Gang's "Rapper's Delight", often called the first commercial rap single, recorded by a group from New Jersey; part of its lyrics had been borrowed from the notebook of the Bronx MC Grandmaster Caz.

Mr. Lindo's sayings come from *Jamaica Negro Proverbs and Sayings*, collected by Izett Anderson and Frank Cundall and published by the Institute of Jamaica in 1910. The book glosses "Hollow gourd mek mos' noise" as the old saw about empty vessels, and "Patient man ride jackass" as meaning that a patient man will put up with a great deal, or will more slowly attain his end. The Longwood neighborhood around Fox and Kelly Streets was among the hardest hit by the fires and abandonment that emptied much of the South Bronx in the 1970s.

After the story of the Group of Six from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 258). The original. Sayings from Izett Anderson and Frank Cundall, *Jamaica Negro Proverbs and Sayings* (Kingston, 1910). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.3

The Votum

> *Und der Friede Gottes, welcher höher ist denn alle Vernunft, bewahre eure Herzen und Sinne in Christo Jesu!*
> *— Philipper 4:7*

This is how they tell it, out at Neudorf.

I. The Grove

Neudorf, Allen County, Indiana · summer 1988

Ewald Kruse was eighty-one the summer it did not rain. He had farmed the ground on the creek east of Fort Wayne since 1931, and since Lorraine died he had lived alone in the farmhouse while his son Norbert farmed it, and at the back of the farm, where the creek bent, stood the grove. It was oaks on the high side and cottonwoods along the water, with eleven rows of plank benches set on cinder blocks under the oaks and a wooden pulpit at the front that Ewald's father had built in 1912. Every September for seventy-six years St. Paul's Lutheran had held its Missionfest there: preaching in the morning and preaching in the afternoon, a guest pastor for each, and in between a dinner on long tables with the pop stand run by the youth.

Three years before, Ewald had a stroke in the machine shed. When he came home from the hospital he could walk with a cane and use his right hand a little, and he could not talk. Julie Bleeke, the speech therapist from the hospital in Fort Wayne, came out twice a week for three years with her flash cards and her picture books. She got him to *ja* and *nein*, which came back in German, and to the name of his granddaughter, Kristin. That was nearly all.

The one whole sentence he had left was the votum, the words Pastor Wehrmeyer had said from the pulpit at St. Paul's at the end of every sermon of Ewald's boyhood, when the services were still in German, before he said the Amen. Ewald had heard it, first in German and later in English, on some four thousand Sundays. It came out of him whole, in his old voice, every word in place, in the German of 1915. Julie said that happened sometimes. The things a person had said or sung ten thousand times lived in some other part of the brain, and the stroke had not found them.

On Sunday evenings, from the time the ground thawed until the corn was in, Ewald walked out to the grove alone with his cane. There was an old school bell on a post by the pulpit, from the parish school that closed in 1962, and he rang it himself, three times. Then he went up and sat in the pulpit chair and said his one sentence to the empty benches.

And the grove answered him. People on the Neudorf road heard it from their cars. Every leaf of the cottonwoods along the creek went at once, with no wind, a roar like the gym at the end of a sectional final, like the whole county on its feet, and it went on about as long as it takes to say the Lord's Prayer, and stopped. High school boys came out to hear it on dares and sat in their pickups on the road with the windows down and did not dare each other again. Norbert had heard it a hundred times. He said it was the trees. Pastor Albers at St. Paul's said it was not a thing he would preach about but he did not doubt it. Ewald, who could not say what he thought, said nothing.

II. The Two Preachers

Missionfest · the second Sunday in September

THAT YEAR THE MISSIONFEST COMMITTEE AIMED HIGH, AND both guests said yes.

For the morning there was Dr. Harold Brandt from the seminary in Fort Wayne, who taught Old Testament and read Hebrew the way other men read the *News-Sentinel*, and who had written a commentary on Isaiah that pastors kept on the shelf behind their desks. He brought most of his

seminarians in a borrowed school bus. For the afternoon there was Pastor Gene Rademacher of Trinity on the south side of the city, the biggest Lutheran congregation in Fort Wayne, whose sermons went out on the radio every Sunday morning, a big warm man with a voice you could hear at the back of a barn. Two charter buses of his people came out behind him, and a line of cars. Between the two preachers there were more people in the grove than anybody at St. Paul's could remember, eight or nine hundred, in folding chairs set out behind the benches and on lawn chairs they had brought from home.

It was ninety-four degrees by ten in the morning. The corn on both sides of the road stood up white and burned, half of it not worth the combine, and the creek was down to a string of pools. There was no wind. In the grove the cottonwood leaves hung straight down on their stems, dry, and some of them had already gone yellow and dropped in August. The funeral home in New Haven had sent out cardboard fans on sticks for every bench, with the Good Shepherd printed on one side and the funeral home on the other.

Ewald was in the grove at seven, in his brown suit, waiting. When Dr. Brandt came walking down from the road with Norbert he went to meet him on his cane as fast as he could go, and took the professor's hand in both of his, and would not let it go. His whole face worked. He could not say *welcome*. He could not say *I have waited all year for this*. He took Dr. Brandt by the elbow and led him to the pulpit and laid the professor's hand on the rail of it, and patted the hand, and stood back.

Pastor Rademacher, who had come early to see the place, looked around at the eleven rows of empty planks.

So who comes out here on an ordinary Sunday night to hear him? he asked Norbert, kindly.

Dad would tell you the grove does, Norbert said. *If he could tell you. You'll hear it today. When the preaching's done, these trees clap. You'll see.*

Rademacher laughed, and then looked at Norbert's face and stopped laughing.

III. The Fan

The grove · the same day

Dr. Brandt preached for fifty minutes in the morning on Isaiah 55, *as the rain cometh down*, which in that summer made people look up. He went through it in the Hebrew, a word at a time, and opened it the way you open a seed catalog, and the seminarians wrote in their notebooks on their knees. It was a very good sermon. At the end of it he lifted his hand and said, *And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus,* and said *Amen*.

The grove was silent. Eight hundred people sat with their cardboard fans going. The cottonwood leaves hung on their stems.

At dinner there was fried chicken and noodles and sliced tomatoes, all that the gardens had made in a dry year, and nine kinds of Jell-O salad on a separate table, and sugar cream pie. In the afternoon Pastor Rademacher preached on the Great Commission for forty-five minutes. He told about a mission school in New Guinea, and a woman in Papua who had walked four days to be baptized, and by the end people at the back of the grove were wiping their eyes. It was a very good sermon too. He lifted his hand and said the votum, in the same English, and the Amen.

Nothing. A sparrow on the oak above the pulpit. Somebody's baby. A car going by on the road.

Rademacher came down from the pulpit smiling and stopped by Norbert on the front bench. *Well,* he said, quietly, *where's my applause?* He meant it as a joke, mostly.

I don't know, Norbert said. He was red in the face. *Every other Sunday there's been a noise like you never heard. I don't know what's the matter today.*

Dr. Brandt had been watching the old man. *Let him say it,* he said.

So Norbert got his father up out of the front bench, and Ewald went up the two steps to the pulpit chair on his cane and sat down in it, facing all those people. He was in no hurry. He took up one of the cardboard fans from the rail and fanned himself twice with the Good Shepherd, slowly, because it was hot, and laid it across his knees. Then he said it, in the voice he had had at fifteen, every word in its place:

Und der Friede Gottes, welcher höher ist denn alle Vernunft, bewahre eure Herzen und Sinne in Christo Jesu.

The cottonwoods went.

Everybody who was there tells it the same. There was no wind; the paper plates on the dinner tables did not lift, and the fans did not stir in people's laps. Every leaf on every cottonwood along the creek turned at once, and the sound came down over the grove like the floor of the world had split open under the benches. People took hold of the planks with both hands. Rademacher's pocket hymnal slid off his knee. A seminarian stood straight up and did not know he had stood. It went on about as long as it takes to say the Lord's Prayer. Then it stopped. The leaves hung still on their stems again, and a few yellow ones came down slowly through the air into the aisle.

Ewald fanned himself once more and got up and went back to his bench.

IV. The Pie Table

The grove · late afternoon

AFTERWARD, AT THE TABLES, TRINITY'S PEOPLE DID NOT KNOW what to make of it, and some of them were sore. Their pastor had preached his heart out. The professor had preached for fifty minutes out of the Hebrew. And an old farmer said one sentence, in German, that every one of them had heard their own pastor say ten thousand times, and the trees went off like the sectional. One man from the radio committee said those trees played favorites. Another said, laughing a little, that they were Missouri Synod trees and only understood German. People laughed at that, though not all of them.

Dr. Brandt did not laugh. He went looking for somebody who could tell him, and Norbert said to ask Julie, who knew his father better than any of them now; she had come out to the house twice a week for three years, and she had come today on her own time. Julie Bleeke was thirty-four and had grown up on a hog farm near Hoagland and still kept her

hair the way she had at her confirmation. She was standing at the pie table cutting sugar cream pie into eighths with a cake server.

I understand he can't say anything else, the professor said.

Hardly a thing, she said. *Ja and nein. His granddaughter's name. That's three years' work.* She lifted a piece onto a paper plate. *And that.*

He waited.

Dr. Brandt, you know a great deal more Bible than I do, she said. *Everybody here knows that. You know it in Hebrew. All Ewald has got left is one verse, and half the time he can't find the words for his own coffee. But every Sunday night of his life he's gone out there and said it like it was so. He keeps it. He doesn't have anything else to keep, so he keeps that, and I've watched him, and I believe he lives in it, the peace. I think he knows what it means better than anybody here. I think the grove knows he does.* She handed him the plate. *Isn't there something in Matthew about that? We had it for memory work.*

The professor knew which verse she meant. Julie had it in the King James, the way the children at St. Paul's had all learned their memory work then, and she said it for him while he held the plate:

> *But when ye pray, use not vain repetitions, as the heathen do: for they think that they shall be heard for their much speaking.*
>
> *— Matthew 6:7*

Dr. Brandt stood there a while. Then he said it himself in Luther's German, half under his breath, the way he had learned it from his own grandmother in Seymour sixty years before: *sollt ihr nicht viel plappern wie die Heiden.* You shall not babble much. He said he had never once in his life noticed that it said that.

He ate the pie standing up.

• • •

The buses left at five, and the cars after them. The seminarians stacked the folding chairs on the hay wagon. By seven the grove was empty and the light came in long and low and yellow under the oaks, through the dust that was over everything that year.

Dr. Brandt had driven a mile toward Fort Wayne and turned his car around. He parked on the Neudorf road and walked back in across the stubble, and stood at the edge of the oaks where he would not be seen.

Ewald was alone in the grove, going down the rows of benches with his cane in one hand and a feed sack in the other, picking up paper plates and the cardboard fans. He worked his way along the front row to the pulpit chair. There was one fan still lying on the seat where he had left it, with the Good Shepherd on it, and a yellow cottonwood leaf on the Good Shepherd. He stood looking at it for a while. Then he picked up the leaf and turned it over in his fingers, the dark side and the pale side, and put it in his suit pocket, and put the fan in the sack.

Background

The verse

> *A man is not a supporter of the law because he talks much; even if a man has learnt little, but sees the law bodily, he is a supporter of the law, a man who never neglects the law.*
>
> Dhammapada 259, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Ekudāna lives alone in a forest grove and knows only one verse, an "exalted utterance" about the heedful sage who has no grief. On Observance Days he sounds the call to hear the Dhamma himself and recites it, and the deities of the grove shout their applause with a noise like the earth splitting open. Two learned monks who know the whole canon come with five hundred followers each; he welcomes them gladly and asks them to teach. One recites and one expounds, and the grove stays silent. Then the old elder takes the fan, sits in the preacher's seat, and says his one verse, and the deities roar. The offended monks complain to the Buddha that the deities play favorites, and the Buddha answers that one is a bearer of the Dhamma by seeing it, not by saying much. Read the full commentary story.

Allen County, Indiana

Allen County, Indiana, 1988

German Lutheran immigrants filled the country around Fort Wayne in the nineteenth century. A Fort Wayne pastor began training men for their ministry in the 1840s, and the seminary formally organized there in 1846 was handed over to the new Missouri Synod soon after its founding in 1847; Concordia Theological Seminary moved to St. Louis in 1861 and later to Springfield, Illinois, and came back to Fort Wayne in 1976. Rural Lutheran congregations across the Midwest kept up annual mission festivals, outdoor services in a farmer's grove with plank benches, a guest preacher, a potluck and a pop stand. Many Lutheran pastors still end the sermon with Philippians 4:7, a blessing called the votum. A stroke that takes away most speech can leave behind words a person has said or sung thousands of times; the Max Planck Society notes that people with aphasia can often still produce song lyrics and formulaic phrases.

The summer of 1988 brought drought and heat across the Corn Belt. In Indiana, according to the U.S. Geological Survey, statewide rainfall was nearly eight inches below normal by the end of September, groundwater fell to record lows in many wells, and crop yields ran from half to about four-fifths of the year before.

After the story of the Elder Ekudāna from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 259). The original. Scripture from the Luther Bible (1912 revision) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.4

The Milk Crate

> *Thy young beard has attained to maturity, whereas thou hast remained immature, as thou wast.*
> *— Eflākī, Acts of the Adepts, tr. James W. Redhouse (1881)*

This is how it got told, on Grand River Avenue.

I. The Door

Grand River Avenue, Detroit · March 1993

The bus from Metro Airport let them off in front of a storefront with a hand-painted sign, FULLER'S RECORDS & BOOKS, and a steel grate rolled halfway up. There were thirty of them. Most were from Berlin, a few from Frankfurt and Rotterdam, two from Osaka who had met the others at the airport by accident and been adopted. They worked in record shops and clubs. They had saved since the summer. For two years they had been playing records made in this city in cellars under a city that had been cut in half, and they had come to see where the records came from, the way people go to see a river's source.

What most of them wanted to see was one man. His records had no names on them. They came in plain white sleeves with a stamped label, and in the smooth ring of the run-out groove, where the needle goes when the music is done, someone had scratched by hand a small circle with a dot in it. That was all. In Berlin they called him the Old Man. Nobody could remember who had started it. It was what the records sounded like: patient, unhurried, as if whoever made them had already heard everything and was not in any hurry to tell you about it. Somebody had heard he was one of the first, from back before anyone in Europe had a word for it. Somebody had heard he was nearly sixty and had worked at

a plant. A Fuller's phone number was written on the back of one of the sleeves in ballpoint, and that was why they had come here.

As they came up to the door it opened from inside, and a boy came out backward, pushing it with his shoulder, with two long cardboard boxes of records in his arms.

He was small, five feet or a little under, in a hooded sweatshirt and a knit cap, with a round smooth face. He looked about fifteen. He held the door with his heel for the first of them, and then the next, and the next, and they went in past him one after another, thirty people, saying thank you in three languages and not looking at him. When the last one was in he let the door close and went off down Grand River in the slush with his boxes, toward a car with one gray fender.

Inside it smelled of old paper and radiator heat. There were bins of used records down the middle of the room and shelves of used books along both walls to the ceiling, paperbacks and old hardcovers with the cloth gone soft, and at the back, behind the counter, a man of sixty-some in a knit kufi and cardigan was writing in a ledger. His beard was white. He had big hands and wore half-glasses on a cord.

They knew him at once. They had decided in the bus. This was the Old Man, or if not, then the man who would take them to him. Jens, who had organized the trip and had the most English, went to the counter and put out his hand.

The man shook it. He looked past Jens at the thirty of them standing among the bins with their bags, and he took his time about it.

As-salaam alaikum, he said. *Idris Fuller. You're the people from Germany.*

They said they were.

Then you just missed him, Mr. Fuller said. *Did you see the elder go out?*

They looked at each other.

No, Jens said. *No one went out. Only a boy.*

A boy.

A boy carrying boxes. He held the door.

That was no boy, Mr. Fuller said. *That was him.*

Somebody laughed and stopped. One of the women from Osaka said something to the other in Japanese, softly. Jens held up a hand, about chest high, flat, as if he were measuring a child against a doorframe.

But he was very small.

He's small, Mr. Fuller agreed. *He was small at seventeen when he came in here the first time to buy a drum machine off a man who owed me money, and he's small now. He's thirty years old. He's been making those records since before your wall came down. He sweeps this store for me on Saturdays.*

II. The Beard

The back of the store · the same afternoon

He came out from behind the counter and went to the shelves on the left wall, and ran a finger along them without looking, and took down a fat old book with a cracked spine and the gilt gone off its lettering. He did not open it right away. He stood with it in his hands, looking at the thirty of them, and at their good boots and their careful clothes and the bags they had carried four thousand miles to put records in.

Rumi, he said. *The poet. You know him?*

Some of them did.

This is an Englishman's book from a hundred years ago. In the back are stories about Rumi that his people told after he was dead. One day he met a Christian monk in the road. A monk with a big beard. And Rumi asked him which one was older, him or his beard.

He found the page with his thumb, the way you find a place you have found many times, and read it to them through the half-glasses, slowly, in the voice of a man reading a lease aloud to somebody who cannot.

> *The monk replied: "I am twenty years older than my beard. It came forth that number of years later." Jelāl answered him: "Then I pity thee. Thy young beard has attained to maturity, whereas thou hast remained immature, as thou wast. ..."*
>
> *— Eflākī, Acts of the Adepts, in The Mesnevi, tr. James W. Redhouse (1881)*

He closed the book on his finger.

I'm sixty-three, he said. *I put twenty-nine years in at Dodge Main till they shut it. This beard came in white all at once the year my wife passed, and people started calling me Elder at the masjid that same week, like the beard did it. Men been calling me wise ever since on account of the color of my face hair.*

He tapped the book against the counter.

That boy you walked past. Thirty years old. I never once heard him tell a lie, not even the easy kind, not even about whose drums he used. He doesn't drink. He never hit anybody. I saw a man swing on him once in a club downtown, in '89, a man twice his size, and he just stepped in under the arm and held on to him till the man got tired and started crying. He doesn't put his name on anything. He gives his money away faster than I can pay him. He plays all night and takes what they give him and sweeps up after. You came a long way to find an old man. That's the oldest man I know.

He put the book back on the shelf in its place, and went behind the counter, and picked up his pen.

He's playing tonight, he said, writing. *Down by the river. I'll give you the address. Don't take the bus. Walk the last part.*

III. The Windows

A warehouse loft near the Detroit River · that night until morning

IT WAS THE FOURTH FLOOR OF A BUILDING THAT HAD MADE something once, stoves or cigar boxes, nobody there knew, with a freight elevator that did not work and a stairway that smelled of rain. The east wall was all windows, tall factory windows with a hundred small panes, some of them broken and taped. Below them, beyond the railroad tracks,

WAS THE RIVER, BLACK, AND ACROSS THE RIVER THE LIGHTS OF Windsor, which was another country.

There were maybe two hundred people. The thirty came in together, and stood together for the first hour, and then did not.

He was at the far end on a plywood platform behind two turntables and a mixer on a door laid across sawhorses. The table was made for a taller man. Under his feet, so that he could reach, was a plastic milk crate turned upside down, with a dairy's name stenciled on the side, and he stood on it all night and did not once look down to find it.

He did not talk on a microphone. He did not raise his hands. He stood with his cap off now, and his round face lit from below by the little lamp on the mixer, and he looked like a boy at a science fair. When he took a record out of its white sleeve he held it by the edges and looked at the grooves before he put it down, every time, the same way, as if he had all the time in the world and so did the record.

What came out was what they had heard in Berlin and had not been able to explain. It did not hurry. It went on and on and kept arriving. It took them by the back of the neck and set them down somewhere and left them there to find their own feet. Around three in the morning Jens noticed he had not thought about anything for an hour, and that the woman from Osaka beside him was crying without any change in her face, and that he did not need to know why.

Toward six the windows began to go gray. Then blue. The river came up out of the dark under them, wide and slow and the color of a knife, with ice along the near edge, and the light came in through the hundred small panes and lay across the floor in long squares, over the people dancing and the people sitting against the walls and the people asleep, and climbed the far wall a pane at a time.

He had been bringing the music down for an hour so gradually that nobody felt it go. When the sun came over Windsor it was a single held chord and a heartbeat under it, and then only the heartbeat, and then he lifted the needle and let the record run out into the groove, and in the quiet you could hear it going round, a soft tick, a soft tick, and the gulls outside over the water.

He stepped down off the crate. He was small again. He was the size he had been in the doorway on Grand River with his arms full of boxes. Nobody laughed. Nobody in that room was looking at the size of him.

The thirty of them were sitting on the floor in the long squares of light, close together, the way people sit after a funeral or a wedding, and none of them said anything. None of them needed to. Later, on the plane, they would try and fail. Jens would say only that he had gone to Detroit to meet an old man and had met one.

The man who had organized the party came and gave him an envelope. He folded it once without opening it and put it in the pocket of his sweatshirt. Then he took a broom from against the wall by the stairs and began to sweep, starting at the platform, working down the long floor toward them through the light, a little at a time, the way he did everything, and when he came to the thirty of them sitting there he swept carefully around them.

The milk crate stayed where he had left it, upside down on the plywood, with the sun on it.

Background

The verses

> *A man is not an elder because his head is grey; his age may be ripe, but he is called `Old-in-vain.'*
>
> Dhammapada 260, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He in whom there is truth, virtue, love, restraint, moderation, he who is free from impurity and is wise, he is called an elder.*
>
> Dhammapada 261, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya ("Bhaddiya the Dwarf") was a monk so small and young-looking that people took him for a novice, though he was an elder and fully awakened. In this commentary story he leaves after attending on the Buddha just as thirty monks from the forest arrive. The Buddha asks whether they saw an elder go out; they say they saw only a novice, and a very small one. The Buddha tells them he does not call a man an elder because he is old and sits in an elder's seat, only one who understands

the truths and harms no one, and the thirty monks are awakened as they listen. Read the full commentary story, or about Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya.

Detroit, Michigan

Detroit, *1993*

Detroit techno was made in the mid-1980s by young Black musicians, most famously three high-school friends from suburban Belleville, who recorded in their basements on drum machines and synthesizers and released records on small local labels. By the late 1980s the music had found a larger audience in Britain and Europe than at home, and a second wave of Detroit artists followed in the early 1990s, many of them pressing their records in small runs with plain labels and little or no information about who made them. After the Berlin Wall fell, techno became the sound of the city's new clubs in empty buildings; Tresor, opened in March 1991 in the vaults of a former department store on Leipziger Strasse, released records by Detroit artists on its own label.

Mr. Fuller's plant, the Dodge Main assembly plant in Hamtramck, closed in 1980. His book is Sir James Redhouse's 1881 translation of the first book of Rumi's *Mesnevi*, which includes a selection of anecdotes about Rumi from Shams al-Dīn Aflākī's fourteenth-century *Manāqib al-ʿĀrifīn*, the "Acts of the Adepts."

After the story of Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 260 and 261). The original. Anecdote of Rumi from Eflākī's *Acts of the Adepts*, in *The Mesnevi*, tr. James W. Redhouse (1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.5

Devil Grass

> *Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, for you know that we who teach will be judged with greater strictness.*
> *— James 3:1 (Goodspeed)*

Now the way I heard it, at Douglas Long Beach.

I. The Board Cover

Engineering, the Long Beach plant · October 1959

THE DRAFTING ROOM WAS ON THE SECOND FLOOR AND RAN the length of a city block, two hundred boards in rows under the fluorescent tubes, every board with a drafting machine clamped to the top edge and a man on a stool in front of it, and here and there a woman. It was quiet the way a library is quiet, which is to say there was a sound under everything, two hundred pencils going and the tick of the machines' protractor heads locking and unlocking, and the hiss of the air conditioning that had been put in for the vellum and not for the people. The airplane they had drawn had gone into service with United and Delta in September. Now the changes were coming back, the way they always did, in stacks.

Lloyd Ambrose had the second board from the window in the wing group. He had come out from Wichita in 1941 when Douglas was hiring anybody who could hold a pencil, and he had been a layout man since the war, and his lettering was the best in the building. People said that, and he had heard them say it. Single-stroke Gothic, upper case, an eighth of an inch high, every letter leaning exactly nowhere, every O a true O, every R with its leg kicked out at the same angle as every other R. He did it freehand. He had a Leroy set in his drawer and never used it. When the

new men came up from the training school, somebody always walked them past Lloyd's board to look at his title blocks, the way you'd take a visitor to see the ocean.

Russ Hiatt had the board behind him. Russ had silver hair at fifty and the kind of face they put in shirt advertisements, and he talked beautifully, and so did Lloyd. They were the two best talkers in Engineering. At the coffee cart, at the Christmas party, at the retirement lunches at the coffee shop on Lakewood Boulevard, when somebody needed to say a few words, it was Russ or Lloyd who said them. Lloyd had won the area contest at Toastmasters two years running. The section chief, Mr. Voss, almost never said anything to anybody, so it fell to them.

On the Friday before Halloween, Lloyd came back early from lunch and found four of the young detailers at Irene Kostka's board.

Irene was the senior checker in the wing group. She had come in during the war, one of the women they hired off the street when the men went, and when the men came back she had not gone home. She was past fifty now, a heavy woman in cardigans who ate her lunch at her board out of waxed paper and did not talk at the coffee cart. Her lettering was a disgrace. It was fast and crabbed and leaned every which way, like a doctor's, and Lloyd had once heard Russ say that if Irene's initials were not in the check box of a drawing you could not be sure the drawing was finished, and if they were, you could not be sure they were initials.

The detailers had her drawings rolled and rubber-banded on the next stool and had stripped the old cover off her board, a sheet of pale green vinyl worn grey and scored through in a hundred places where her knife had cut tape. They were laying down a new one. Ray Delgado held one end and the Lund boy the other, and Judy Pratt ran a steel scale along it to push the bubbles out, and the Okamoto kid stood by with the tape. They did it carefully, the way you'd make a bed for somebody who was sick. When it was down they put her drawings back and set her pencils in a row, sharpened, the leads pointed on the sandpaper pad, and her coffee from the cart, black, with a saucer over it to keep it warm.

Lloyd went to his own board. His cover was eleven years old. He had never once thought about it until now.

II. Lunch in the Buick

The parking lot · the following week

Nobody ate in the cafeteria who could help it. Most of Engineering ate in their cars with the windows down and the radio on, in the big lot by the airport fence, and watched the airplanes. Lloyd and Russ ate in Russ's Buick, which had the better radio.

It's not that I want my pencils sharpened, Lloyd said.

Lord, no.

It's the standard. You look at what's coming out of that training school. Half of them can't letter. They can't make a numeral eight. They come up here and they attach themselves to whoever's nice to them, and they learn whatever that person happens to do. Irene's a good checker. Nobody says she isn't. But her hand is a mess, and every one of those kids is going to letter like her in five years.

Russ unwrapped a sandwich. *What we ought to have,* he said, *is a rule. Nobody puts a line on a released drawing until he's done six weeks of lettering with one of the senior layout men. No matter where he trained.*

The way they used to do it at Santa Monica before the war.

The way they used to do it everywhere. It'd be good for the airplane.

It would, Lloyd said. He was already seeing it. He saw the memo, with his name on it and Russ's. He saw a Group Leader rating, which neither of them had ever been given, and the money that went with one. He saw young men coming up to his board in the morning with a question and a cup of coffee, and the walk past his title blocks becoming a thing they had to do and not just a thing they were shown.

An airliner went over low, coming in, all four engines at once, and they waited until they could hear each other.

You'd better do the talking, Russ said. *You're better with Voss.*

Nobody was better with Voss. But Lloyd said he would.

III. The Chief's Desk

Mr. Voss's desk · Friday afternoon

Harlan Voss had a grey steel desk at the end of the room, out in the open with everybody else, where he could see the whole wing group without seeming to look. He was from Red Oak, Iowa. He had been a structures man before he was a section chief and he still did the stress checks on the hard ones himself, at home, at night. He was an elder at a Presbyterian church in Long Beach and he had never been heard to raise his voice or tell a joke. When you talked to him he looked at you the whole time with his hands folded on the blotter, and it was hard to keep talking.

Lloyd talked well. He had written it out at home and practiced it in the bathroom mirror and he did not need the paper. He talked about the standard. He talked about the training school. He said that a drawing was a public document and might be in a file somewhere for forty years and that somebody they would never meet would have to read it. He did not mention Irene Kostka. He did not mention a Group Leader rating. Russ stood behind him and nodded at the right places. It took about four minutes, and when he was done he knew it had been good.

Voss sat a while.

That's a sound idea, he said. *It's the way I was taught. A man ought to learn to letter from somebody who can letter.*

Lloyd felt Russ shift behind him.

But that's not why you're asking, Voss said.

He reached into the stack on the corner of his desk without looking and slid out a released drawing, a wing rib, and turned it around so they could read it. Lloyd knew the drawing. He had done the layout. In the check box, in a scrawl, were Irene's initials. Down the margin, in the same scrawl, in red pencil long since erased but still showing in the tooth of the vellum, were nine corrections. Lloyd remembered every one. Two of them would have put a rib in the wrong place on an airplane that was now carrying people to Chicago.

I don't count a man a draftsman because of his lettering, Lloyd, Voss said. *Or because he can talk. You both letter better than anybody in this building. You talk better than anybody in it. I've known that for fifteen years.*

He opened the shallow drawer of his desk, where other men kept their slide rules, and took out a small blue book with a soft cover, worn white along the spine, and opened it to a place he did not have to look for. He read it the way he read everything, flat, like specifications.

> *What wise, intelligent man is there among you? Let him show by his good life that what he does is done in the humility of wisdom. But if you cherish bitter feelings of jealousy and rivalry in your hearts, do not pride yourselves on it and thus belie the truth. Such wisdom does not come from above. It is earthly, animal, demon-like. For wherever jealousy and rivalry exist, there will be confusion and every low action.*
>
> *— James 3:13–16 (Goodspeed)*

He closed the book and put it back in the drawer.

The kids go to Irene because Irene doesn't care whether they go to her or not, he said. *When you don't care either, I'll send you all of them.*

That was all. He picked up his pencil, and they understood that they had been let go.

IV. The Runner

Lakewood · Saturday

Lloyd lived on Hayter Avenue in Lakewood, in a two-bedroom stucco house that had cost him nine thousand dollars in 1951 with nothing down, on a street of eighty houses that had all been built in about a week. He had put in dichondra in front, like everybody, because it stayed green and flat and you hardly had to mow it, and it looked from the street like a green felt tabletop. He was proud of it. The only trouble with it was the devil grass.

Devil grass was what everybody in Lakewood called Bermuda grass. It came over from the vacant lots and the neighbors and the strip by the

curb, and it threw out runners under the dichondra, flat, like wire, and sent up blades every few inches along them, coarse and grey-green and ugly. Lloyd had been pulling it for eight years. He pulled it every Saturday morning, along with the rest of the street. You took hold of the blades and pulled, and they broke off at the runner, and the lawn looked clean, and in a week it was back. Everybody knew that. Nobody on Hayter Avenue had ever done anything else.

He was on his knees on a folded bath mat at seven in the morning, with the coffee going cold on the step. He had not slept well. He kept hearing it, the flat voice. When you don't care either. He had gone over the four minutes in his head all night the way you go over a drawing that came back from check, and every time he went over it he found that he had believed every word he said, and that none of it was why he had said it.

He took hold of a tuft of devil grass to pull it and stopped.

He went into the garage and got the narrow trowel Marjorie used for her bulbs. He came back and worked the point in beside the tuft, gently, and lifted, and found the runner, white where it had been out of the light, and followed it. It went under the dichondra toward the walk. He lifted the dichondra over it with his fingers and laid it back down. It went a foot and branched, and he followed both branches. One of them went under the edge of the concrete. He lay down flat on the walk on his stomach in his Saturday clothes and worked the trowel in under the slab, a quarter inch at a time, and drew it out. The other went clear across to the Hendersons' side. He followed it there too, on his knees on their lawn, and Ed Henderson came out in his robe for the paper and looked at him and went back inside.

It took him most of the morning. When it came up at last it came up all at once, the way a thread comes out of a hem, and he sat back on his heels holding it. It was longer than he was tall. There were joints all along it every few inches, and a fine beard of white root at every joint, and at the far end a knot of roots the size of his fist that had been sitting under his lawn since Eisenhower's first term, sending the stuff up, while he pulled at the tops every Saturday and called it weeding.

He laid it out on the sidewalk in the sun, the whole length of it.

• • •

On Monday he took his new layout, the trailing-edge change, not to the checker who usually had his work but down the row to Irene Kostka's board, and stood there with it until she looked up.

Would you look at this for me, Irene?

She looked at him a moment longer than she needed to. Then she cleared a space on the new green cover and unrolled it and weighted the corners and went over it with her red pencil, not saying anything, all the way down, the way she went over everybody's. She found two. She put a crabbed little red mark beside each of them that could have been a check or a letter or nothing at all, and rolled it back up and handed it to him.

Thank you, Lloyd said.

The runner was still on the sidewalk when he came home that evening, dried out and gone the color of straw, with the beard of roots curled up at every joint. He left it there all week, where he had to step over it going to the car.

Background

The verses

> *An envious greedy, dishonest man does not become respectable by means of much talking only, or by the beauty of his complexion.*
>
> Dhammapada 262, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He in whom all this is destroyed, and taken out with the very root, he, when freed from hatred and wise, is called respectable.*
>
> Dhammapada 263, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, some senior monks at Jetavana notice the young monks and novices dyeing robes and doing other services for their own preceptors. The elders, who are skilled with words and expert in the letter of the teaching, get no such attention, and they ask the Buddha to rule that young monks, wherever they have learned the Dhamma, must not rehearse it until they have trained under them, so that their own gain and honor will grow. The Buddha sees that the rule would be

proper in itself but that they want it for their own gain, and tells them he does not count them accomplished for their talk: only one in whom envy and the rest have been cut out at the root is truly accomplished. Read the full commentary story, or about bhikkhus, the Buddhist monks, and their ordination and training.

Long Beach and Lakewood, California

Long Beach and Lakewood, *1959*

Douglas Aircraft built its DC-8, its first jet airliner, at a new factory at Long Beach Airport. The first one rolled out on April 9, 1958, first flew on May 30, 1958, and entered service with Delta and United on September 18, 1959. Before computers, every part of an airplane was drawn by hand, in pencil on vellum, in drafting rooms that held hundreds of boards; the work went from layout to detail to checker, whose initials on the drawing meant it could be released. Lettering in a standard single-stroke Gothic hand was a point of pride, and the trade itself all but disappeared once computer-aided drafting arrived.

Next door, the tract city of Lakewood went up between 1950 and 1953, 17,500 houses in under three years, sold to veterans with no money down on thirty-year loans. Lakewood incorporated in 1954. Dichondra, a low creeping plant with small round leaves, was a fashionable lawn in Southern California through the 1950s, and Bermuda grass, which the locals called devil grass, invaded it by underground runners that had to be dug out entire or would come back.

After the story of a company of bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 262–263). The original. Scripture from Edgar J. Goodspeed, *The New Testament: An American Translation* (1923). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.6

Seven O'Clock

> *It is necessary to the happiness of man, that he be mentally faithful to himself.*
> *— Thomas Paine, The Age of Reason, Part I (1794)*

Here's how I heard it, for what it's worth, in Hays.

I. The Pin

Fort Hays State University · fall 2013

Travis Dreher shaved his head every Sunday morning, at the hour his mother was at Mass in Victoria, and he wore a red letter A on a pin on his jacket, the scarlet A that atheists had started wearing a few years before so they could find each other. He was twenty-one and a junior in political science. He had grown up in the shadow of St. Fidelis, the big twin-towered church out on the plain at Victoria that his great-great-grandfather had helped build, hauling limestone in a wagon the way every man in the parish had to, and he had quit believing at fifteen, all at once, the way some people get saved. Now he ran the Fort Hays Freethinkers, nine members on a good night, in a seminar room on the second floor of the student union, and he ran a YouTube channel called Prairie Reason, which had four thousand subscribers.

He was a good talker. He had read everything. He would stand at the tables outside the union with his phone propped on a stack of books, filming, and take on anybody: the Baptist preacher who came up from Great Bend twice a semester with a sign, the Mormon elders in their white shirts, the Newman Center kids. He won most of the time. When he won, he posted it.

When he lost, which was not often, he did something else.

The first time was in September, with Annie Pfannenstiel. She was a nursing student from Schoenchen who taught Sunday school at her home parish and said very little, and she had stopped at his table on her way to anatomy lab and asked him one quiet question about something he had said. Then she asked another one. Ten minutes later a small crowd had gathered, and Travis could feel it going the wrong way, the way you can feel a car start to slide on gravel. So he smiled and said, *Look, this deserves a real format. Thursday, seven o'clock, the seminar room upstairs. I'll stream it. Bring whoever you want.* She said all right.

On Thursday he went live at a quarter to seven. He sat alone at the front of the empty room with the camera on him and the clock on the wall behind him, and he said, *So, we're here. We said seven. Let's see if she shows.* At three minutes to seven he said, *This is what happens, guys. Every time. They'll talk to you on the sidewalk, but put a camera on it and set a time and they run.* At one minute to seven he ended the stream. The clip he cut from it was called CATHOLIC NO-SHOW, and it got eleven thousand views by Sunday.

Annie Pfannenstiel came up the stairs at three minutes after seven, out of breath from the parking lot, and found the room dark.

II. The Format

The student union, second floor · October and November

After that it was what he did. He lost a long argument in October to one of the Mormon elders, a boy from Idaho who had read more Hume than he had. He lost one in November to an old Lutheran pastor from Ellis who had come to the table only to buy a raffle ticket. Each time Travis said the same easy thing. *This deserves a real format.* Each time he named a day, a time and the room upstairs. Each time he went live early, talked to the empty chairs, and cut the clip. ELDER GHOSTS DEBATE. PASTOR WON'T SHOW. The comments loved them. Subscribers went past six thousand. A man in Phoenix sent him a fifty-dollar tip with a note that said *keep exposing them.*

The Freethinkers loved it too, most of them. They had grown up in Ellis, Russell and Rooks Counties, in towns with a church on every corner and nobody to say any of this out loud to. Travis said it out loud for them, with his shaved head and his red pin. When he came into the Tuesday meeting after a clip went up, they clapped.

Not all of them. Mariah Leiker, who kept the club's money in a cash box, said one night that it was funny how none of them ever showed. Travis said that was the point. Mariah did not say anything else. But she had been at the table the day the Lutheran pastor beat him, and had heard what time Travis told him. She had been sitting in the union food court with her calculus homework when the old man came up the stairs at four minutes past the hour, holding a printout of the event, and found the door locked and the lights off.

III. Mrs. Haas

Twenty-second Street, Hays · a Saturday in December

The oldest member of the Fort Hays Freethinkers was Lorene Haas, who was seventy-nine and not a student. She came to every Tuesday meeting in a quilted coat with her cane hooked over the back of her chair, and mostly she listened. She had been a preacher's wife for thirty-one years, in Holiness churches in Russell, Osborne and Smith Counties. She had played the piano for every service, taught the women's Bible study, and buried a daughter. Then one winter, the year after her husband died, she sat down at her kitchen table with the Bible she had taught from all her life and read it straight through, Genesis to Revelation, like a book, in nineteen days. When she closed it she did not believe any of it anymore. She said so out loud, to her sister, her son and her pastor, and lost most of her friends in Russell County. That had been twenty-two years ago. She said it was the most honest thing she had ever done and she would do it again.

Mariah Leiker went to see her on a Friday. On Saturday morning Lorene called Travis on the phone and asked him to come by the house.

She lived in a small brick house on Twenty-second Street with a wheelchair ramp her son had built. She let him in and sat him at the kitchen table and did not offer him anything. On the table, between them, was an old book with a cracked brown cover and the spine taped. She had her phone in her hand, and on the phone was the clip with the Lutheran pastor, paused on Travis sitting alone in front of the clock.

Travis, she said. *Mariah tells me you give these people one time and then go on the air before it. That you say seven o'clock and start at a quarter till, and tell everybody they didn't come. Is that so?*

He thought about it. He had a good many answers ready, about format and fairness and how they would have run anyway. He found that he did not want to say any of them in this kitchen.

It's so, he said.

Why?

He did not have an answer to that one.

Lorene Haas put the phone face down on the table. *I sat in a church for thirty-one years with men who had the collar and the Bible and the right words,* she said. *Some of them were the best men I ever knew. Some of them would lie to you about what time it was, to win. It wasn't the collar that made the difference. That pin doesn't make you anything either, and neither does shaving your head. A man who'll fake a no-show to get eleven thousand views is not a freethinker. He's just a preacher for the other side.*

Travis looked at the table.

You want to know what makes one, she said, *it's the little lies. You quit those. The little ones and the big ones, every one of them, all the way down, until there aren't any left to quit. Then call yourself whatever you want.*

She pulled the old book over and opened it to a place she had marked with a feed-store receipt. It was a Paine, an *Age of Reason* from 1900 that her father had kept in the barn, she said, where her mother would not find it. She read it to him the way she had once read the Psalms to the women's Bible study, slowly, with her finger under the line.

> *But it is necessary to the happiness of man, that he be mentally faithful to himself. Infidelity does not consist in believing, or in disbelieving; it consists in professing to believe what he does not believe.*
>
> *It is impossible to calculate the moral mischief, if I may so express it, that mental lying has produced in society. When a man has so far corrupted and prostituted the chastity of his mind, as to subscribe his professional belief to things he does not believe, he has prepared himself for the commission of every other crime.*
>
> *— Thomas Paine, The Age of Reason, Part I (1794)*

He's talking about priests there, Lorene said, and closed the book. *He means it for us too.*

IV. Seven O'Clock

The student union · January 2014

He took the three clips down that night. It cost him about four hundred subscribers, and the man in Phoenix wrote to ask what had happened to him. He did not answer.

He wrote to Annie Pfannenstiel instead, and to the elder from Idaho, who had gone home, and to the Lutheran pastor at Ellis, and told each of them what he had done, in so many words. Then he asked Annie whether she would still have the debate.

They had it on the third Thursday in January, at seven, in the seminar room on the second floor. Twenty-two people came, which was more than had ever come to anything the Freethinkers did, and Lorene Haas sat in the front row with her cane hooked on her chair. Travis did not go live early. He sat at the front of the room with the camera off and his hands on the table and watched the clock on the wall, and nobody in the room said anything. He had let his hair start to grow out over Christmas, a dark fuzz, and he had left the pin on his dresser.

At 7:01 the door opened and Annie Pfannenstiel came in, out of breath from the parking lot, and said she was sorry, the lot behind the union was full.

He lost, narrowly. He knew it, and so did the room. He posted all of it, an hour and forty minutes, with nothing cut, under the title *Pfannenstiel v. Dreher, January 16.* It got three hundred views. Mariah Leiker watched it twice. A few of the others in the club said afterward that they had not much liked watching it, at first, because some of the little things he was owning up to on camera were things they did too, the easy story, the round number, the thing you say to win, and they had never once thought of those as lies.

The video is still up. In the first frame, before anyone has said anything, the camera is on the wall behind the empty chair at the front of the room, and the clock on the wall says seven.

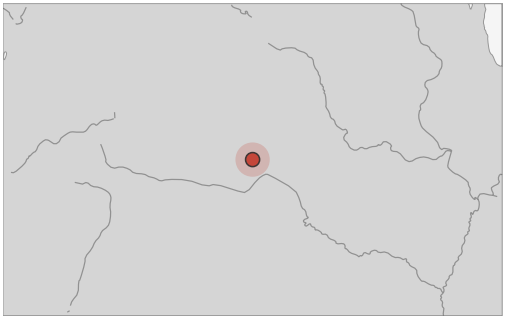
Background

The verses

> *Not by tonsure does an undisciplined man who speaks falsehood become a Samana; can a man be a Samana who is still held captive by desire and greediness?*
>
> Dhammapada 264, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who always quiets the evil, whether small or large, he is called a Samana (a quiet man), because he has quieted all evil.*
>
> Dhammapada 265, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk named Hatthaka wins his arguments with other sects by a trick. Whenever he is losing, he names a time and place to continue the debate, goes there early, and tells the people gathered that his opponents are too afraid to come, which he calls an admission of defeat. The Buddha hears of it and sends for him. When Hatthaka admits it is true, the Buddha tells him that a shaven head does not make a man a monk if he lies and is driven by desire and greed. He is a monk who has quieted wrongdoing of every kind, small and great. Read the full commentary story.



Hays, Kansas

Hays, 2013

Hays is the seat of Ellis County in western Kansas and home to Fort Hays State University. Volga Germans, German-speaking Catholics from Russia, began settling the county in 1876, and their villages of Victoria, Schoenchen, Munjor and Pfeifer still give the county its character. At Victoria the parishioners built the church of St. Fidelis, the "Cathedral of the Plains," finished in 1911. Every member of the parish twelve or older was asked to give $45 and to haul six wagonloads of Fencepost limestone and four of sand each year until it was built.

In the years around 2010 a wave of public atheism sometimes called the New Atheism reached small campuses through student groups, books and YouTube channels, where filmed debates with believers drew large audiences. The Out Campaign, endorsed by Richard Dawkins, gave atheists a scarlet letter A to wear on pins and shirts. Many in the movement took The Age of Reason (1794–1807), Thomas Paine's attack on revealed religion, as a founding text. Its first part opens with Paine's own creed, in which he says he believes in one God and declares that "my own mind is my own church."

After the story of Hatthaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 264–265). The original. Text from Thomas Paine, The Age of Reason (1794). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.7

Brother Fly

> *... the rules of pilgrims were to abide under a strange roof, to thirst for their fatherland, and to pass on their way in peace.*
> *— Bonaventure, Life of St. Francis VII*

J'ai ouï dire ceci, on the levee at New Orleans.

I. The Shells

Paris and La Rochelle · 1719

He was called Jacquot la Coquille. A woman who may have been his mother set him on a church porch near the Halles when he was six, with his arm bound up in a rag to look withered, and at twelve he was taken into the trade proper. Begging in Paris had its ranks and its masters, like the drapers. There were the ones who chewed soap and fell down foaming, and the ones with a paper saying their house had burned, and the ones who went as pilgrims of Saint James, with cockle shells sewn on hat and cape and a staff with a gourd, and a tale of the long road home from Compostela.

Jacquot was a pilgrim. He had the shells, the staff, a cape that was more patch than cape, and a beard to his breastbone. He had never been south of the Orléans gate. In twenty years he had not done one day's work, and he said so with some pride. He lived on what was given, he said, like the birds of the air and the friars.

Then the Company wanted people for the Mississippi. In November of 1718 it was cried in Paris that vagabonds might be taken up and sent, and that winter the archers the streets called the bandouliers of the Mississippi went through the city, paid, it was said, by the head. They lifted Jac-

quot off his church steps, shells and all. He was held with others until spring, walked to La Rochelle on a chain, and put into a ship.

II. The Sack

New Orleans · summer 1724

They were set ashore on the sand at Biloxi, where there was nothing, and a good many did not get up from it. Jacquot got up. He reached the new town on the river in time for the September storm of 1722, which blew down most of what was standing, and he stayed, having nowhere to go that was not farther.

By the summer of 1724 it was a town of straight streets ruled through mud, huts of cypress posts, a levee and a guardhouse. And he found that a beggar there had no one to beg from. There were soldiers who had not been paid, clerks of the Company, men and women shipped out as he had been, and Africans who were not let to own even themselves. A man with shells on his hat got a laugh the first day and after that nothing. He lived on the levee off what fell from the boats.

The Capuchins had come the year before, friars of the province of Champagne in brown habits with long pointed hoods, corded and sandaled and bearded. Their superior had hardly been able to find a room to put them in, and fewer than thirty people came to his Sunday Mass. The Company was bound to keep them and paid when it remembered. With them was an old lay brother, Frère Zacharie, who had carried the alms sack for his convent at home for forty years. Nobody told him to take it up in Louisiana. He took it up. Each morning he went along the huts and the levee asking, for the love of God, for whatever there was: a measure of rice, some corn, a fish, a candle end. Part went to the fathers' table and the larger part to the sick in the King's hospital. Between rounds he split the wood, carried the water and dug the graves, and he spoke very little.

Jacquot watched him for a month, the way one tradesman watches another. Then one morning he stood in the brother's path on the levee, with people about.

Brother. A word, between two of the same trade.

The old man stopped.

You ask at doors. I have asked at doors since I could stand. You have a beard and I have a beard. You have a cord and a patched gown; look at this cape. You own nothing. They chained me by the neck for owning nothing and sent me here for it, and you came over as a passenger. Now the whole town calls you frère, down to the commandant. Very well. I live on alms the same as you. Let them call me frère too. And you may begin.

Frère Zacharie set down the sack. He looked at the shells.

Where does Saint James lie?

In Spain.

You have been?

I have been to the Mississippi, which is farther.

The people standing by laughed, and the brother very nearly did.

Our father Francis had a name ready for you, he said. *You want to be called brother. Here it is.*

> *If he beheld any man wandering about in idleness, and fain to feed on the toil of others, he thought he ought to be called "brother fly," for that, doing no good himself, and spoiling the good done by others, he made himself an hateful pest unto all.*
>
> *— Bonaventure, Life of St. Francis V*

There were flies enough on the levee that morning to make the point, on the fish in the sack and on both their faces.

And you? said Jacquot. *With your sack? What are you but the same fly in a hood?*

If the sack were the whole of it, I would be. No one is a friar for asking. Nor for the gown, nor the beard. You wear a pilgrim's shells. Francis said what a pilgrim's rules are, and there are three of them.

> *For he said that the rules of pilgrims were to abide under a strange roof, to thirst for their fatherland, and to pass on their way in peace.*
>
> *— Bonaventure, Life of St. Francis VII*

Which of the three have you kept?

Jacquot opened his mouth. He had a strange roof, if the sky counted. He thirsted for Paris, but he understood well enough that Paris was not the country meant. And he had not passed one day of his life in peace with anybody, least of all the people who fed him.

The brother picked up his sack and went on down the levee. He said nothing more to him that day, nor, so far as anyone heard, on any day after.

A sergeant's wife was standing by, and two boatmen, and a clerk from the Company's store. It is told that the clerk went to confession that week for the first time since France, and that one of the boatmen carried the sack as far as the hospital. And by evening the whole levee had a name for Jacquot. They called him Frère Mouche.

III. The Hat

New Orleans · the fever months and after

He wore it as a joke at first. He answered to it with a bow and held out his hand. It brought him no more than the shells had.

In the fever months the hospital filled. One morning Jacquot saw the old brother coming out of the shed backward, bent double, hauling a dead soldier by the armpits because there was nobody for the feet. Jacquot looked up and down the levee. Then he went over and took the feet. Nobody had asked him and nobody thanked him. The next morning he was there before the brother was, and after the burying he carried the water.

Nobody saw him cut the shells off. Some children found seven cockles in the mud below the levee and played at pilgrims with them for a week. He never again asked any man to call him anything. He slept under the eave of the hospital shed, which was not his, and ate what the brother's sack brought, after the sick had eaten.

It is said that when a new father came out from France and asked who the bearded man digging in the cemetery was, a child told him, *That is*

Brother Fly, and that Frère Zacharie, who did not often correct anyone, said, *Leave off the fly.*

Jacquot wore the same hat to the end of his life. It had seven pale places on the felt, each in the shape of a shell, where for twenty years the sun had not got at it.

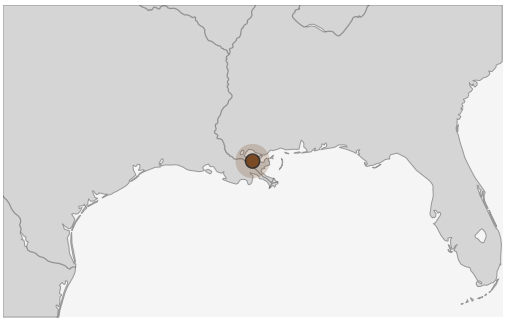
Background

The verses

> *A man is not a mendicant (Bhikshu) simply because he asks others for alms; he who adopts the whole law is a Bhikshu, not he who only begs.*
>
> Dhammapada 266, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who is above good and evil, who is chaste, who with knowledge passes through the world, he indeed is called a Bhikshu.*
>
> Dhammapada 267, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin who has gone forth in another sect and lives by begging reasons that since the Buddha calls his own alms-gathering disciples *bhikkhus* (the word means one who asks for alms), he ought to be called a bhikkhu too, and goes and says so. The Buddha answers that he does not call a man a bhikkhu merely because he receives alms or keeps the outward forms, and speaks the two verses. That is the whole story. Read the full commentary story.



New Orleans, French Louisiana

New Orleans, 1724

John Law's Company of the West, chartered in 1717, was obliged to people Louisiana and could not find volunteers. An ordinance proclaimed in Paris on November 10,

1718, allowed vagabonds to be arrested and transported, and police squads nicknamed the *bandouliers du Mississippi* swept up beggars, deserters, smugglers and people whose families or enemies wanted them gone; they were marched to the ports in chains. The abuses were notorious, and a royal decree of May 9, 1720, ended the forced shipments. Many of those landed on the Gulf Coast died of hunger and disease. New Orleans, founded in 1718, became the colony's capital in 1722, the year a September hurricane leveled most of it. The Historic New Orleans Collection tells the story in "The Vagabond City."

In 1722 lower Louisiana was assigned to the Capuchins of the province of Champagne, a reformed branch of the Franciscans who by rule live on alms. Their superior, Father Raphaël, arrived in 1723 and reported that he could hardly find a room for his friars and that fewer than thirty people came to Sunday Mass; the brick-and-timber parish church was begun in 1725 (see the Catholic Encyclopedia on New Orleans). False pilgrims with cockle shells were an old and recognized class of Paris beggar. Jacquot and Frère Zacharie are invented, and whether the Louisiana Capuchins sent a brother out with the sack, as their houses in France did, is not recorded. Francis's "brother fly" and his rules of pilgrims are in St. Bonaventure's life of the saint, which every Franciscan knew; it is quoted in E. Gurney Salter's English of 1904.

After the story of a certain Brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 266–267). The original. Scripture from St. Bonaventure's Life of St. Francis, translated by E. Gurney Salter (1904). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

19.8

The Pickle Stone

The wise err neither in regard to their man nor to their words.
— Confucian Analects 15:7

Nyoze gamon, on Pine Street.

I. The Saturday People

Pine Street, San Francisco · spring 1961

The temple on Pine Street was two flats of a wooden house with the wall between the front rooms taken out. Reverend Kuwahara had died in the fall of 1957, and headquarters in Japan had been promising a new priest ever since. Until one came, his widow unlocked the door. Kuwahara Tome was seventy-one. Everyone called her Okusan, the lady of the house. She had come from Fukui in 1914 to marry a man she knew from a photograph, and she had kept his temple through one earthquake scare, one Depression, and three years in the Utah desert, and she saw no reason to stop for a funeral.

Fumi Hamada kept the temple's books and did Okusan's English for her. Fumi was forty-three, born on Buchanan Street, a bookkeeper at a dry-goods store on Post. She was in the basement kitchen most Saturdays and every Sunday with Mrs. Oka and Mrs. Tani and the two Nakagawa sisters, and so she saw both kinds of Americans that came in those years.

The first kind came on Saturday night. Mr. Lyman Dunmore rented the social hall for ten dollars a month to lecture on what he called the Zen way. He was fifty, a big soft man in a Japanese farmer's jacket, and he taught evenings at an academy out in Pacific Heights. Twenty or twenty-five people came to hear him, and afterward the temple women gave them supper, because people were in the building at suppertime.

When the plates were empty Mr. Dunmore stood up. He put his palms together. He thanked the ladies in Japanese that Mrs. Tani said sounded like a man reading a seed packet, and then he thanked them in English. *May you be well, may you be happy, may your years be long.* Then he gave them his advice. They were not to walk home by way of Geary, where the city was tearing out the blocks for the new expressway, because the wreckers left mud and boards with nails in them. They were not to go down Fillmore after dark. Mrs. Oka had lived on Geary Street since 1919, except for the three years, and she had buried a husband from that house. She thanked him for telling her.

Still, it was thanks. The women talked about it over the dishes. *He says too much,* Mrs. Tani said, *but he says it.*

The second kind came in the dark. At a quarter to six every morning Okusan climbed the stairs and struck the bell the way she had heard her husband strike it for forty years, and seven or eight young Americans sat down on the floor of the front room and faced the wall. Over on Bush Street the big temple, the one in the old synagogue, had a new priest from Japan and Americans of its own, more of them every month. Pine Street got the ones who wanted a smaller room. There was a postal clerk named Walt Kessler who sorted mail nights at the Rincon Annex. There was a girl called Joan from the Art Institute, and a merchant seaman, and a house painter, and two boys from State College. They had read that Zen was past words. They sat forty minutes without moving, which Fumi could not have done, and they did not say a word in the building, coming or going.

On Sundays the women fed them. Rice gruel, pickled plum, tea, and Mrs. Oka's takuan, the yellow radish pickle she had made every November of her life. The sitters ate with their eyes on their bowls. They washed the bowls and stacked them. They bowed at the kitchen door and went up the steps to the street, and that was all.

Like feeding the gas meter, Mrs. Tani said.

The Saturday ones say it was good, said Mrs. Oka. *These ones, I don't know if they noticed it was food.*

The younger Nakagawa sister said maybe they should save the good takuan for Saturday.

II. Sit Beside

May 1961

Fumi told Walt Kessler. She had not planned to. He was holding the street door for her one Sunday with his eyes lowered like a man in a hospital corridor, and she heard herself say, *You know they think you don't like the food.*

He looked up. He had a long, plain, worried face. *We thought we weren't supposed to talk.*

Who told you that?

He thought about it. *Nobody,* he said.

The next morning after the bell, all of them stayed behind in the front room, and Walt asked Okusan, and Fumi put it into Japanese. Okusan listened with her hands folded on her apron. She did not smile, but she rarely did.

After eating, say gochisōsama, she said. *It means, it was a feast. Then don't run away. Sit beside. Mrs. Oka makes the takuan. Ask her how long.*

That was the whole instruction. Fumi wrote the word on the back of an offering envelope so they could practice it.

The first Sunday was hard to watch. Eight Americans said *gochisōsama* in eight different ways and then sat down on the benches next to the women, holding their knees. The seaman asked Mrs. Tani if she had lived in San Francisco long. Mrs. Tani said forty-four years. Walt asked Mrs. Oka how long for the takuan, and Mrs. Oka, who had not been asked a question by an American since a soldier asked her for her family number in 1942, told him.

Two weeks to dry the radishes on the rack, until you could bend one end to the other. Then into the barrel with rice bran and salt, the salt weighed and not guessed. Then the lid and the stone on the lid, and you waited for the water to come up. Three months, better four. She showed him with her hands how a radish should bend. Walt bent an imaginary

radish back at her. It was the first time Fumi had seen him look like anything but a man waiting for bad news.

After that the women could not do enough. The gruel became rice and miso soup and a piece of salted salmon each. Mrs. Tani brought eggs. Joan from the Art Institute was shown how to wash rice until the water ran clear, and was told she had been doing it wrong all her life, and came back the next week for more of that. The seaman was invited to the Nakagawas' on a Wednesday and came away with a jar of pickled scallions and a tin of rice crackers. In June the Redevelopment Agency's letter came for the house on Geary, and it was Walt's Chevrolet panel truck and six sitters that carried Mrs. Oka's forty-two years down three flights and over to her daughter's on Sutter Street. Nobody had asked them to. They had heard about the letter on a kitchen bench.

They still sat at a quarter to six, and still did not talk in the front room. Fumi noticed that the sitting had not changed at all.

III. The Stone

October 1961

It got back to Mr. Dunmore. The Saturday suppers had not got any worse, but there was no salmon in them, and one of his own circle, a tall girl with a braid, had mentioned the Sunday breakfasts in his hearing.

He said it at the table, to his own people, loud enough for the kitchen. *We follow the wordless teaching. We are the ones who understand silence. Upstairs they have made a coffee hour of it. They sit forty minutes and then gossip with the cooks about radishes.* He had a brown library book with him, one of a long set, and he opened it at a slip of paper and read.

> *He who knows (the Tâo) does not (care to) speak (about it); he who is (ever ready to) speak about it does not know it.*
>
> — Tâo Teh King 56, tr. James Legge

Fumi, in the kitchen doorway with a dish towel, put it into Japanese for Okusan as well as she could. She was angry and it came out short.

Okusan was at the pickle barrel in the corner, seeing to the last of the year's takuan. She listened to the end. Then she lifted the stone off the lid. It was a flat gray stone the size of a loaf, and it had come back from Topaz in 1945 in the bottom of a suitcase, because everything she had stored in 1942 was gone when she got home, the old stone with it. She carried it in both arms across the social hall and set it down on the table in front of Mr. Dunmore, between the soy sauce and his book.

This one is quiet too, she said in English. *Sixteen years. Never one word. Please, ask it something.*

Nobody at the table moved. The stone left a wet ring on the oilcloth.

Then she said something in Japanese that Fumi could not follow, in the stiff old style, a schoolgirl's recitation. She said it twice. *Rongo,* she told Fumi. *The Master's sayings. We had it by heart at the girls' school, every one of us. Your Mr. Lao is in the same library. Let them look.*

It was Walt who looked. He went to the Main Library on his way to work on Monday and found the same translator two shelves down and copied it out on the back of a mail-sack tag. He read it aloud the next Saturday, standing, because Okusan told him to.

> *The Master said, 'When a man may be spoken with, not to speak to him is to err in reference to the man. When a man may not be spoken with, to speak to him is to err in reference to our words. The wise err neither in regard to their man nor to their words.'*
>
> — Confucian Analects 15:7, tr. James Legge

Mr. Dunmore said that Confucius was hardly Zen.

Okusan had brought something else out of the kitchen that night. It was her steelyard, the hand scale she weighed the salt on, a wooden beam with brass marks, a pan on one end, and a weight on a string. She held it up by its loop and let the beam swing and settle.

Quiet is easy, she said, and Fumi gave it in English a sentence at a time. *A stone can do it. A man who doesn't know anything can do it. A man who is afraid can do it, and a stingy man who knows something and won't tell. You*

have to weigh. This is good, I take it. This is bad, I leave it. Every time, both sides. A person who does that, when he talks it is all right, and when he is quiet it is all right.

She hooked the scale back on its nail. She did not say which side she had weighed Mr. Dunmore on, and she gave him the same supper as everyone else.

• • •

Mr. Dunmore went on lecturing in the social hall until the new priest came, and paid his ten dollars on the first of the month, and thanked the ladies after every supper. But the tall girl with the braid came up the stairs at a quarter to six the next Sunday, and a man who drove a laundry truck came with her. They sat forty minutes facing the wall. They said *gochisōsama* afterward and sat down on the bench beside Mrs. Oka, and by Christmas there were nine more from Saturday.

In November the women put up the new takuan, and the sitters helped. The radishes had hung two weeks on a rack in the Tanis' back yard and bent end to end. Joan weighed the salt on the steelyard with Mrs. Oka watching the beam. Walt packed the barrel, a layer of radish and a layer of bran, and the house painter and the seaman argued about the Giants the whole time, and nobody told them to hush. When the lid was on, Okusan had Walt bring the stone and set it down in the middle.

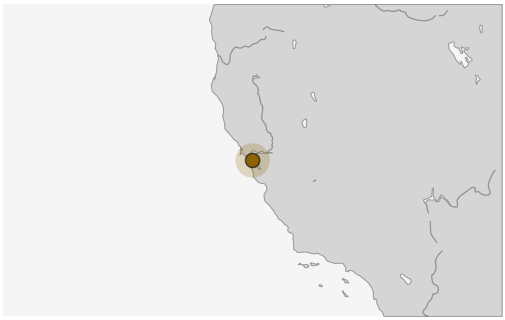
By morning the water had come up over the lid.

Background

The verses

> *A man is not a Muni because he observes silence (mona, i.e. mauna), if he is foolish and ignorant; but the wise who, taking the balance, chooses the good and avoids evil, he is a Muni, and is a Muni thereby; he who in this world weighs both sides is called a Muni.*
>
> Dhammapada 268, 269, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, wanderers of other sects thank their hosts after every meal with blessings and with warnings about mud and thorns on the roads, while the Buddha's monks get up from the table and leave without a word. The householders take offense. The Buddha tells the monks to give thanks and to sit beside their hosts and talk pleasantly with them, and the householders respond by giving more than before. The other sects then complain that the monks talk too much and that they themselves are the true sages, the silent ones. The Buddha answers that people keep quiet out of ignorance, out of timidity, or out of a stinginess that will not share what it knows, and that a sage (*muni*) is one who weighs and puts aside what is harmful. The Pāli plays on *mona*, silence, and *muni*, sage. Read the full commentary story.



Japantown, San Francisco, California

San Francisco's Japantown, 1961

The Japantown of the Western Addition held more than five thousand people before the war. In 1942 its families were removed, most of them by way of the Tanforan racetrack to the Topaz camp in the Utah desert, and many who came back in 1945 found their stored belongings gone. In the late 1950s the city's Redevelopment Agency began clearing the forty-four blocks of its Western Addition project A-1, widening Geary into an expressway and displacing about four thousand people, Japanese American and Black, by the middle of the 1960s. The Pine Street temple, its people and Mr. Dunmore are invented.

These were also the years when Americans raised on paperbacks about Zen started looking for somewhere to sit. Alan Watts's essay "Beat Zen, Square Zen, and Zen" appeared in 1958. In May 1959 the Sōtō priest Shunryū Suzuki arrived to serve the Japanese American congregation of Sokoji, then housed in a former synagogue on Bush Street, and the early-morning sitting he opened to anyone became the San Francisco Zen Center. The two groups in such temples, the families who had built them and the newcomers who came to meditate, did not always know what to make of each other. Takuan is made much as Mrs. Oka describes it. The quotations are

from James Legge's nineteenth-century translations of the *Tao Te Ching* and the *Analects*.

After the story of the sectarians from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 268–269). The original. Scripture from the *Confucian Analects* and the *Tâo Teh King*, tr. James Legge. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

19.9

The Stringer

Uprightness, heed to injure nought which lives.
— Bhagavad Gita 16, tr. Edwin Arnold

I heard it like this, on Hastings Street.

I. Big Boy

Detroit · spring 1943

His mother named him Noble because she wanted the white folks in Lowndes County to have to say it. She told him so when he was small. They will call you boy till you are ninety, she said, but every time they want you they will have to say Noble first, and it will cost them something in their mouths.

It did not work out that way. In Alabama they called him boy. In Detroit, where he came up in 1937 on the Dixie Highway with nine dollars and a cardboard suitcase, they called him Big Boy. He was six foot three and weighed two hundred and twenty pounds, and he had boxed for two years out of the Brewster Center, where Joe Louis had trained, and had won eleven fights and lost two, and in the last one, in Toledo, he had hit a man named Sweeney so hard that Sweeney went to the hospital and never walked right again. Noble quit after that. He went to work in the foundry at Ford's Rouge plant in Dearborn, pouring iron, where most of the colored men at the Rouge worked because it was the hottest and dirtiest work in the place. The foreman on his line called him Big Boy. The men on the line called him Big Boy, or Tate. At the Rouge, nobody called him Noble.

The foundry was like working inside a stove. The cupolas roared day and night, and the iron came down the spouts into the ladles white as

noon, and the sand off the molds got into a man's lungs and his hair and the creases of his eyelids so that he went home every night with a black rim around his eyes, and Lurline made him wash at the sink before he touched the children. It paid better than anything in Alabama ever had. In the spring of 1943 the Rouge was making aircraft engines for the war, and Noble worked six days, and some weeks seven, and slept in the afternoons with a wet towel over his face because the flat on the second floor never cooled down. He had three children, Carl and Ruth and the baby, Odessa, and when he came home they ran to the door and stopped a little short of him, the way everybody did.

On Hastings Street they mostly called him nothing. They stepped out of his way. There had been a night in 1941 at a bar on Hastings when a man had said something about his wife, and three men had needed carrying out, and after that the street knew who he was. He was not proud of it, or he told himself he was not. He went to work and came home and put his pay envelope on the kitchen table for Lurline, and on Sundays he went fishing.

He fished off the shore of Belle Isle, on the Canada side, below the big willows, where the current ran slow along the riprap. Perch, mostly, and rock bass, and white bass in the spring, and now and then a sheepshead that Lurline would not cook. He was good at it the way he had been good in the ring. He did not waste motion. He set the hook short and hard and swung the fish up onto the rocks and had it off and on the stringer before it knew it was out of the water, and the stringer hung down off a willow root into the river with the fish on it alive and turning, so they would keep.

Since March, meat cost red points out of the ration book, and there were never enough red points and never enough meat at the butcher on Hastings even if there had been. A perch off the island cost nothing at all. Every Sunday that spring Noble took the Jefferson streetcar to the bridge and walked across and came home at dark with fifteen or twenty fish, and Lurline floured them and fried them for him and the three children and for whoever on the second floor of the building needed fish that

week, and nobody on the second floor went hungry, and nobody said thank you to his face, because they were a little afraid of him.

II. Names

Belle Isle · Sunday, June 20, 1943

THAT SUNDAY WAS THE HOTTEST OF THE YEAR SO FAR, AND IT seemed like all of Detroit had come out to the island to get out of the heat. Colored and white, war workers, sailors from the armory, families with baskets, kids in the canals up to their knees. The ball fields were full. The beach was full. The grass under every tree was covered with blankets, and along the shore below the willows there was a fisherman every twenty feet.

Noble had his line out and a dozen perch on the stringer by two o'clock. He had taken his shirt off and folded it on the rocks. His knuckles were still scarred white from the ring and from Hastings Street, and the sun was on his shoulders, and he was as easy as he ever got.

Then he saw them coming down the path along the shore.

It was an old woman in a black straw hat and a gray dress buttoned to the throat, walking slow with a cane, and behind her in a line two by two came eleven colored children in their Sunday clothes, holding hands, not one of them running, not one of them hollering. Noble had never in his life seen eleven children that quiet on a hot day. Every so often the old woman stopped and pointed with her cane at something, a heron in the shallows, a turtle on a log, the swallows going in and out under the bridge, and all eleven heads turned to look where she pointed, and stayed looking until she moved on.

He did not know why, but he set his pole down on the rocks. He stood up and wiped his hands on his trousers and stood there with his shirt off, the way you would stand up if a funeral was going by.

The old woman stopped on the path not ten feet from him and turned around to the children.

Now, she said. Her voice was not loud. It carried anyway. *Who are we? I want to hear it. Whole name. Stand up straight.* She pointed her cane at the first child.

Calvin Lee Hughes, Miss Pruitt.

Mister Calvin Lee Hughes. Say it like that. Mister.

Mister Calvin Lee Hughes.

Thank you, Mr. Hughes. The cane moved. *And you?*

Miss Dorothy Mae Barnes.

Thank you, Miss Barnes. And you?

All down the line. Mister Willie Pettaway. Miss Ernestine Coleman. Mister James Earl Sims, who was about five and had to be helped with the Mister. Every one of them said it loud, and every one of them stood up straighter after, as if their name were a coat somebody had just put on them.

Noble stood on the rocks and listened. He felt a thing he had not felt since he was a boy in Lowndes County, in the back of the church, wanting the preacher to call on him. She was asking every one. She was going down the line asking every one, and he thought, she is going to ask me too, and he wanted her to so badly that his hands shook, and he put them behind his back.

When the last child had said his name the old woman turned around on the path and looked straight at him, as if she had known all along he was there.

And you, sir? What is your name?

Noble, ma'am, he said. His voice came out strange. *Noble Tate.*

Mister Noble Tate. She said it slowly, the way she had said all of them.

Then she looked at the stringer hanging off the willow root, where the perch were turning in the brown water, a dozen of them, with the cord through their gills, and the one at the bottom on its side, and she looked at his hands, the white scars on the knuckles, and she looked back up at his face.

That's a fine name, Mr. Tate, she said. *But nobody gets to be noble by hurting things. Not fish. Not men. Not anything that's alive. A man is noble when*

he's got pity on everything that's living, and won't hurt it. That's the only way anybody ever was.

The children looked at him. The heron in the shallows behind them lifted one foot and put it down.

Miss Pruitt took a little book out of the pocket of her dress, a small worn book with a green cloth cover, and opened it where a ribbon was, and did not look at the page.

There was a man in India who carried this in his pocket, she said. *He has the English locked up in a jail right now for being too much like it. Listen.*

> *Uprightness, heed to injure nought which lives,*
> *Truthfulness, slowness unto wrath, a mind*
> *That lightly letteth go what others prize;*
> *And equanimity, and charity*
> *Which spieth no man's faults; and tenderness*
> *Towards all that suffer; a contented heart,*
> *Fluttered by no desires; a bearing mild,*
> *Modest, and grave, with manhood nobly mixed,*
> *With patience, fortitude, and purity;*
> *An unrevengeful spirit, never given*
> *To rate itself too high.*
>
> *— Bhagavad Gita 16:1–3, tr. Edwin Arnold (1885)*

Manhood nobly mixed, she said, and shut the book. *Good afternoon, Mr. Tate.*

She turned and went on down the path with her cane, and the eleven children went after her two by two, and James Earl Sims looked back at him over his shoulder the whole way until they were around the bend.

Noble stood there a long time. He did not know what had happened to him. He would try for the rest of his life to tell Lurline, and never get closer than this: that it was as if somebody had opened a door in a hot room that he had not known was a room.

Then he got down on his knees on the riprap and pulled the stringer up out of the water. He worked the cord out of the gills of the first perch, careful, and held it in the river in his two hands until it found its strength

and went. Then the next one. A boy fishing twenty feet down the shore stopped and watched him with his mouth open. *Mister, what you doing? You turning them loose?* Noble did not answer. He did not have an answer. He did it eleven times. The twelfth one, the one at the bottom, had been on its side too long, and he held it in the current a long time, and it did not go, and finally he let it drift away downstream, white side up.

He left the pole on the rocks. He did not decide to. He just never picked it up again.

III. The Bridge

Belle Isle · Sunday evening

The trouble had been going on all afternoon in little pieces, on the far side of the island and by the casino and the ball fields, colored boys and white boys, a shove, a fistfight, somebody's girl, somebody's blanket, things people said. Noble had heard it the way you hear thunder off over Canada. Toward evening it was not little pieces anymore.

A hundred thousand people were trying to get off the island at the same time, and there was only the one bridge, the long bridge they had just renamed for General MacArthur, half a mile of it, and by the time Noble got to the foot of it with his shirt back on, it was packed rail to rail with people and cars, and there were fights breaking out on it in the middle of the crowd, and sailors in white were wading in from the island end.

He found Miss Pruitt and her children at the foot of the bridge, against the stone railing. She was standing in front of them with her cane, very straight, and the children were holding hands in a knot behind her, and James Earl Sims was crying without making any sound at all.

He did not ask her. He picked up James Earl Sims and set him on his shoulders, and picked up the Coleman girl, who was the next smallest, on his arm, and said, *Hold on to each other. Hold on to my coat. Miss Pruitt, you hold on to me.* And he walked them across.

It took most of an hour. The crowd was so thick in places it moved like one thing. Somewhere ahead there was a sound of glass. Somewhere behind them a woman was screaming a name. Halfway over, a white boy no older than seventeen, in a sailor's undershirt, with blood running out of his nose, turned around in the crush and saw Noble coming, the size of him, and swung at him with everything he had, and hit him on the cheekbone.

Noble stopped. The boy stood there in front of him with his fist up, white in the face, waiting to die. Noble could have broken him in half. Every man within ten feet of them knew it, colored and white, and they all went still, and in that whole roaring bridge there was a little space of quiet around the two of them.

Noble put his free hand up and steadied James Earl Sims, who was holding on to his ears.

Let us by, son, he said.

The boy let them by.

On the Jefferson Avenue side Noble put the children down in a line and Miss Pruitt counted them, all eleven, twice, touching each head. Then she looked at the bruise coming up on his cheek. She did not say anything about it. She said, *Thank you, Mr. Tate,* and took them home on foot, two by two, up toward Hastings Street.

IV. Hastings Street

Paradise Valley · Sunday night

The story came down Hastings Street a little before midnight, from the bars and the clubs, from mouth to mouth up the stoops and through the open windows of the flats where nobody could sleep for the heat: that white men had thrown a colored woman and her baby off the Belle Isle bridge into the river.

It was not true. Nobody knew that yet. Across town, in the white neighborhoods, a different story was going around just as fast, about a white woman on the same bridge, and that was not true either. But on Hastings Street that night there was not a man who did not believe it, be-

cause there was not a man who could not believe it. Every one of them had come up from somewhere it could have happened.

By one o'clock there were men in the street with bricks and bottles and pieces of pipe. Windows were going on the white-owned stores along Hastings. Somebody had set a fire.

Three men came up the stairs to the second floor and knocked on Noble's door. He knew them all. One was from his line at the Rouge. *Come on, Big Boy,* they said. *They threw a baby in the river. Come on. We need you. You know what you can do.*

He did know. That was the thing. He stood in the doorway in his undershirt with the bruise on his cheek and he knew exactly what he could do, and his hands knew it, and the old heat came up in him the way it used to in the ring when the bell rang, and he wanted to go. He wanted to go more than he had wanted anything since the afternoon.

Behind him Lurline stood in the kitchen doorway with the baby, not saying anything.

He thought about the perch on its side, drifting off downstream, white side up. He thought about the boy on the bridge with his fist in the air, waiting to die.

My name is Noble, he said. The men in the hall looked at each other. *I'm not going.*

When they had gone down the stairs he went down after them, and sat on the front stoop of the building the rest of the night, a big man in an undershirt in the dark, and nobody came up those steps, and nobody went down them.

V. Monday

Paradise Valley · June 21

Before dawn on Monday white mobs were on Woodward Avenue, a few blocks west, pulling colored men off the streetcars on their way to the early shift and beating them in the street, and turning over colored people's cars. By the middle of the morning they had come east, into the Valley, and the police came in after them in squad cars and on

FOOT, WITH RIOT GUNS, AND IT WAS THE COLORED PEOPLE THE police were shooting.

Noble had not gone to work. Nobody on Hastings Street had gone to work.

A little after noon, from the stoop, he saw a boy he knew come running out of an alley across the street with something in his arms, a carton of cigarettes, or nothing, Noble never found out. It was the Pettaway boy's older brother, Leon, fifteen. A patrolman at the corner fired twice. Leon went down on the sidewalk with his leg turned under him and lay there calling for his mother.

Noble went across the street. The patrolman swung the riot gun around at him, a big colored man coming at a run, and for a moment it was all going to end right there on Hastings Street with Noble Tate face down on the sidewalk, the way it ended that week for seventeen colored men in Detroit. Noble stopped in the middle of the street and held his hands out from his sides, open, both of them, the white knuckles turned up. He held them there.

He's a child, he said. *I'm going to carry him to the hospital. That's all I'm going to do.*

The patrolman looked at him a long time over the barrel. Then he looked away, up the street, and Noble went and picked up Leon Pettaway and carried him nine blocks to the hospital in his arms, with the blood running down into his own shoes, and stayed there until a doctor came.

The hospital hallway was full. People sat on the floor along both walls, holding towels to their heads, holding each other. A colored doctor with his sleeves rolled to the shoulder went down the line looking at each one and saying a word to the nurse behind him, and when he got to Leon he looked at the leg and then up at Noble, who was standing over the boy with his hands hanging at his sides, red to the wrist.

You his father?

No, sir. I live across the street.

What's your name?

It was the second time in two days. *Noble Tate,* he said.

Well, Mr. Tate, you can go wash. You got him here in time.

Monday night the soldiers came, federal troops in trucks, with bayonets, and set up in the streets, and there was a curfew, and it was over. Thirty-four people were dead. Twenty-five of them were colored. Leon Pettaway lived, and walked with a limp the rest of his life, like a man named Sweeney in Toledo whom he never heard of.

VI. Walden

Hastings Street · July

Her name was Augusta Pruitt. She had taught school for forty-one years in Macon, Georgia, and had come north in 1940 to live with her niece over a barbershop on Hastings Street, and she did not go to church, which the church women on Hastings Street could not forgive her. She spent her Sundays instead taking whatever children she could collect on the streetcar to Belle Isle, to look at things. She called it nature study. She did not charge.

Leon Pettaway's little brother Willie was one of hers, and that was how she found out where Noble lived. Willie told her the whole thing on the streetcar going out to the island the next Sunday, the policeman and the riot gun and the big man in the middle of Hastings Street with his hands out, and she listened all the way across the bridge without saying anything, and then she pointed out a kingfisher.

She came to see Noble one evening in July, when the bruise on his cheek had gone yellow. She climbed the two flights with her cane and sat at the kitchen table and drank a glass of Lurline's iced tea, and talked with Lurline about Macon, and did not say much to Noble at all.

When she was getting up to go he asked her the one thing.

Miss Pruitt. That book. The man in India.

Mr. Gandhi.

He give up fishing too?

She laughed, the first time he had heard her. *I don't know that he ever started. There was a man in Massachusetts who did, though. Mr. Thoreau. He lived by himself in the woods by a pond and wrote it all down, and Mr. Gandhi read him too. He wrote, No humane being, past the thoughtless age of boyhood,*

will wantonly murder any creature which holds its life by the same tenure that he does. She said the words carefully, as if she had them by heart. *And he wrote, I cannot fish without falling a little in self-respect. He said he was good at it, too. He had a knack for it, like you.*

Same tenure, Noble said.

Same terms. Same lease. You and the perch. She put her hand on the doorframe. *And the boy on the bridge, Mr. Tate. And the policeman. All of us on the same terms.*

She went down the stairs one at a time, and he listened to her cane all the way down.

• • •

On Sundays after that he went out to the island with Miss Pruitt and the children. He carried the little ones over the bridge on his shoulders when their legs gave out. He learned the names of the birds. At the Rouge the foreman still called him Big Boy, and Noble answered to it, because a man has to eat, but on Belle Isle, every Sunday, an old woman in a black straw hat would stop on the path and turn and point her cane at him at the end of the line.

And you, sir?

Mister Noble Tate.

Down below the willows, on the riprap, a pole lay out in the weather all summer where he had left it, until the line rotted off it, and the reel rusted, and the cottonwood fluff drifted over it and caught in the guides, and the children ran past it without looking, and the perch went by it in the brown water, holding their lives on the same terms as anybody.

Background

The verse

> *A man is not an elect (Ariya) because he injures living creatures; because he has pity on all living creatures, therefore is a man called Ariya.*
>
> Dhammapada 270, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a fisherman whose name is Ariya, "Noble," is fishing with hook and line near the north gate of Sāvatthī when the Buddha and his monks pass by. He throws down his pole and stands still. The Buddha stops nearby and asks Sāriputta and the other elders their names one by one, and the fisherman thinks, he will ask me too. The Buddha does ask, and when the fisherman answers "Ariya," the Buddha says that those who take life are not called noble, and that the noble are those who harm no living thing. At the end of the verse the fisherman enters the stream. The word *ariya*, noble, is the same one used for the Buddha's Four Noble Truths. Read the full commentary story, or about the word ārya.

Detroit, Michigan

Detroit, 1943

Between 1941 and 1943 nearly 400,000 people, Black and white, moved to Detroit from the South to work in the war plants. Housing was desperately short and tension ran high. In February 1942 white residents fought to keep Black defense workers out of the Sojourner Truth housing project, and in June 1943 some 25,000 white workers walked out at Packard when three Black men were promoted to the assembly line. By the end of the decade about a quarter of the workers at Ford's River Rouge complex, which built aircraft engines and other war goods, were Black. Meat had been rationed by red points since March 1943, as the National Park Service's account of home-front meat rationing describes.

On Sunday, June 20, 1943, fights between Black and white youths broke out on Belle Isle, and that evening they spread onto the crowded bridge, renamed for Douglas MacArthur the year before, as more than 100,000 people tried to leave the island. False rumors raced through the city overnight: in Paradise Valley, that whites had thrown a Black mother and her baby off the bridge; in white neighborhoods, that Black men had attacked a white woman. White mobs beat Black riders pulled off Woodward Avenue streetcars, and police poured into Paradise Valley. By the time federal troops arrived on the night of June 21, thirty-four people were dead, twenty-five of them Black, seventeen of those killed by police. Edwin Arnold's translation of

the Gita, *The Song Celestial*, was the first version Gandhi ever read, as a student in England, and Thoreau's reflections on giving up fishing appear in the chapter "Higher Laws" of *Walden* (1854).

After the story of Ariya the Fisherman from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 270). The original. Scripture from the Bhagavad Gita in Edwin Arnold's translation, *The Song Celestial* (1885), with words from Henry David Thoreau's *Walden*. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

19.10

Six Bottles

> *Do nothing in haste, look well to each step, and from the beginning think what may be the end.*
> *— Edward Whymper, Scrambles Amongst the Alps (1871)*

So hab ich es erzählen hören, at the Turnhalle in Denver.

I. The Pledge

The Turnhalle, Denver · spring 1887

There were six of them that year in the mountain section of the Denver Turnverein, and by the first of July there was nothing left that they had not done to get ready.

They had taken the pledge in May, standing in a row under the gaslights of the Turnhalle with their hands up: six weeks before the mountain, no lager and no tobacco. For a Turner this was not a small thing. Gustav Brenner's father made beer for a living, and Gustav went home every evening through the smell of the malt house and drank water at supper while his brothers watched him. They had walked to Golden and back on Sundays with forty pounds of sand in their packs. They had climbed the rope to the rafters hand over hand until their palms split, and done it again the next night on the splits. Dr. Fritz Haller had bought an aneroid barometer in a leather case from an instrument maker on Larimer Street and read everything there was to read about the peak: the Hayden survey, the English lady's letters, every paragraph the *Rocky Mountain News* had printed since the first party went up in 1868. Karl Ostertag had spent the whole of the past winter alone as watchman at a shut-down mine above timberline on the Divide, five months without speaking to anyone but a cat, and said the cold no longer meant anything

to him. Gustav could stand on his hands on the parallel bars for two minutes by the Turnhalle clock and not a muscle in him trembled, so that the younger boys came to watch him the way people watch a candle flame in a room with no draft. And the Lenz brothers, Theo and Willi, who made cigars on Fifteenth Street, had already been to the top of Longs Peak once, in the summer of 1885, and knew the way.

The Turnlehrer watched all this from his chair by the vaulting horse and said very little.

His name was Johann Baptist Ruf, and he had taught gymnastics in that hall since there had been a hall. He was fifty-seven. At nineteen he had carried a musket for the revolution in Baden and been inside the fortress at Rastatt when it surrendered, and he had come to America on the strength of that with nothing but a trade and a bad shoulder, and then fought again with the Western Turner Rifles of Missouri because, he said, he had already lost one republic and did not intend to lose two. He had never been up Longs Peak. He believed in nothing he could not lift, and he did not go to any church, and the Turners loved him the way boys love a man who has never once told them they were good when they were not.

In July he announced that he was going with them as far as timberline, to keep the camp. Nobody argued. Nobody argued with Ruf.

II. Timberline

Below Longs Peak · August 1887

They went up from Longmont by wagon and from the ranch at the foot of the trail on foot, with a mule to carry the blankets and the coffee and a wooden crate that Ruf had packed himself in Denver and would not let anybody else lift. They made camp in the last of the trees, where the spruce stood twisted and knee-high and flagged all on one side by the wind, and above them the mountain went up out of the dwarf willow into the Boulder Field and on up past it, a great square grey head with the snow lying in its seams, so close and so big in the evening

LIGHT THAT WILLI LENZ SAID IT LOOKED LIKE IT WAS LEANING over to see what they had brought.

Ruf opened the crate by the fire. In the straw were six brown bottles of Denver lager, sweating from the walk. He carried them one at a time to a snowbank in the lee of a boulder fifty yards from camp, where a drift had lasted the summer in the shade, and pushed them into it neck-down in a row, and covered them over, and came back and sat down.

After supper the six of them came over to his side of the fire and sat down on the ground in front of him. Somebody had decided they should. They sat the way they sat on the floor of the Turnhalle when he talked to them before an exhibition, with their knees up and their arms around them, and Theo Lenz spoke for all of them because he was the oldest.

Herr Lehrer, we want to tell you something. We've kept the pledge six weeks. Not a glass. We're as strong as we're going to be. The Doctor knows that mountain better than the men who measured it. Karl's not afraid of any cold there is. Gustav could stand on his hands on the top. Willi and I have been up already. The weather is fine. We could go up tomorrow, or the next day, or any day we like. It's as good as done.

Ruf looked at them over the fire a long time.

So, he said. *You have finished it.*

All but the walking.

Then give me something to drink to it. Gustav. Go get the bottles.

Gustav laughed and half got up, and saw the old man's face, and sat down again.

Three years ago, Ruf said, *in September, a lady from Waterbury in Connecticut went up this mountain with a guide. She was very determined. They told her the weather was turning and it was late, and she went on, and she got to the top. I read it in the* News. *She got to the top in the afternoon. And then she came down as far as the notch in the ridge up there, and the storm came, and a little below the notch she could not go on, and the guide went for help, and when they came back for her in the morning she was dead.* He nodded up into the dark where the mountain was. *She had climbed it, you understand. She had been on the top. Ask her if it was as good as done.*

Nobody said anything. The fire popped.

Ruf reached into the pocket of his coat and took out a book, a thick red Philadelphia edition with the corners gone soft, and opened it near the back where a strip of newspaper marked the place. He had bought it in 1873, the year it came to the bookstore on Larimer Street, and every boy in the mountain section had heard him read from it, though never this part. He read it in English, slowly, the way he read everything in English.

> *Climb if you will, but remember that courage and strength are naught without prudence, and that a momentary negligence may destroy the happiness of a lifetime. Do nothing in haste, look well to each step, and from the beginning think what may be the end.*
>
> *— Edward Whymper, Scrambles Amongst the Alps (1871)*

He wrote that, Ruf said, *after the Matterhorn. They got to the top of the Matterhorn, seven of them, the first men ever. Coming down, one slipped, and four of them went off the mountain on the rope.* He closed the book. *Being good is not the top. Being strong is not the top. Knowing everything in the newspaper is not the top. You can stand on your hands on the top, Gustav, and still not be done. Nobody has climbed that mountain until he is sitting here by this fire again. Not one minute before. Then we will drink to it.*

He put the book back in his coat and banked the fire, and they went to their blankets. Willi Lenz said afterward that he did not sleep at all, and that he heard the old man get up twice in the night and go out to look at the sky.

III. The Notch

Longs Peak · the next day

They went at three in the morning by lantern, up through the dwarf willow and the frost, and came into the Boulder Field as the sky went grey, a mile of broken granite heaped as if a city had fallen down there, every block of it rimed white. At sunrise they were at the notch, a hole in the ridge like a keyhole with the whole western world

BLOWING THROUGH IT, AND ON THE OTHER SIDE THE LEDGES went out across the face of the mountain with nothing under them for a thousand feet. Theo went first. Nobody talked. They went across the ledges and up the long gully of loose rock beyond them, where every stone they touched went clattering away below them for a long time while they listened, and then out onto the steep slabs of the last pitch, on their hands and their feet together, and then there was no more up.

The top of Longs Peak is as flat as a parade ground and nearly as large, a field of granite blocks in the sky. It was nine o'clock. They shouted. They shook hands. Willi built a little pile of stones and put his name on a card in a tobacco tin under it. Dr. Haller took the aneroid out of its case and read it three times and wrote the figures in his book and said that the Hayden survey had been out by some feet, and that he would write to the *News* about it. Gustav walked to the very edge of the east face, where the cliff dropped straight down into the dark lake at its foot, and stood there looking down, and the others watched him and knew that he was thinking about standing on his hands, and that he was thinking about Ruf, and that he was not going to.

By eleven the clouds were building over the Divide, white and then not white.

Theo said they would go down now, and Willi wanted another quarter of an hour for the view, and Theo said, *Now,* in the Turnlehrer's voice, and they went.

The storm caught them on the slabs. First it was hail, small and hard as birdshot, bouncing off the rock and filling every crack white, so that the slabs that had been rough going up were greased coming down. Then the light went strange and violet and Karl Ostertag's hair stood up from under his hat, all of it, straight up, and the iron shoes of their alpenstocks began to sing in their hands like bees in a wall. Theo shouted to lay the irons down. They laid them on the rock and lay down flat themselves among the blocks while the thunder came in the same instant as the lightning, the way a door slams, and the whole mountain shook under their bellies.

When it moved off a little they went on down without the alpenstocks, all but Gustav's, which had slid away down the slabs while they lay there and gone over into the gully, and they heard it a long time. They went down the slabs on the seats of their trousers. They went down the gully one at a time, the others waiting with their backs to the wall until each man had stopped and called up that he was stopped. On the ledges Gustav, who could have run across them in the Turnhalle on a beam six inches wide, put each boot down and looked at it there before he lifted the other one, the whole way, and Willi behind him said afterward that it was the longest he had ever seen anyone take to do anything.

Coming back through the notch the hail had turned to wet snow. Just below it on the Boulder Field side they passed a place among the rocks, a hollow out of the wind where a person might sit down to rest for a minute, and none of them sat down. Haller said later that every one of them had looked at it.

IV. The Snowbank

Timberline · that evening

Ruf had kept the fire going since noon. He had been watching the mountain since three in the morning with Haller's spare field glass, and when the storm covered it he had gone on watching the cloud.

They came down out of the Boulder Field in the last of the light, soaked to the skin, one behind the other, Theo first and Gustav last, and walked into the circle of the fire, and Ruf stood up and counted them with his finger the way he counted boys back in from a run along the Platte. Six. He did not say anything. One by one they sat down on the ground by the fire with their knees up, not because anyone told them to, and held their hands out to it, and none of them said the word top, or done, or any word at all.

When the last of them was sitting down Ruf picked up the lantern and walked out to the boulder in the dark. They heard him kicking at the drift. He came back with the bottles in the crook of his arm like kindling,

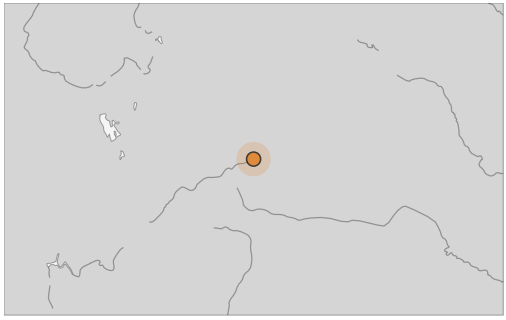
six of them, frosted white from neck to heel, and stood them in a row on the flat rock by the fire, and the snow slid off them in the heat and ran down the brown glass, and the firelight came through.

Background

The verses

> *Not only by discipline and vows, not only by much learning, not by entering into a trance, not by sleeping alone, do I earn the happiness of release which no worldling can know. Bhikshu, be not confident as long as thou hast not attained the extinction of desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 271–272, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a company of monks at Jetavana tell themselves that because they keep the precepts and the ascetic practices, are deeply learned, live in remote places and have mastered the meditative absorptions, they could become arahants any day they wished; some who have already reached the stage of non-return think the same. They come and sit before the Buddha, who asks whether they have finished their work. When they tell him what they have attained, he warns that no monk should think there is little suffering left until the taints are actually destroyed, and speaks these verses; at the end of the teaching all of them become arahants. Read the full commentary story.



Longs Peak, Colorado

Longs Peak and the Turners, 1887

Longs Peak, the highest summit in what is now Rocky Mountain National Park, was first climbed on August 23, 1868, by a party with John Wesley Powell and the Denver editor William Byers. Isabella Bird described her own ascent, in the autumn of 1873,

in *A Lady's Life in the Rocky Mountains*. The usual way up passes through the Boulder Field and a gap in the ridge called the Keyhole, then crosses exposed ledges and climbs steep slabs to a broad, flat summit, and its afternoon thunderstorms are still the mountain's best-known danger. In September 1884 Carrie Welton of Waterbury, Connecticut, reached the summit late in the day with her guide; a storm caught them on the descent, and she died of exposure a short distance below the Keyhole. Edward Whymper wrote the closing words of *Scrambles Amongst the Alps* with the first ascent of the Matterhorn in mind: in July 1865 his party of seven reached the top, and on the way down a slip pulled four of them to their deaths.

The Turners were German gymnastic societies, many founded in America by refugees of the failed revolutions of 1848–49, and the clubs served as gymnasiums and as social, political and cultural centers for German immigrants; many Turners fought for the Union, some of them in Turner regiments such as the 17th Missouri, the "Western Turner Rifles." Denver's Turnverein was founded in 1865. The six climbers and their Turnlehrer are fictional.

After the story of the company of bhikkhus endowed with virtue from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 271–272). The original. Scripture from Edward Whymper, *Scrambles Amongst the Alps in the Years 1860–69* (1871). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 20

The Way

20.1

The Road Book

Indeed, the whole science and practice of the bicycle is "in your eye" and in your will; the rest is mere manipulation.
— Frances E. Willard, A Wheel Within a Wheel (1895)

The way it was told at the club, on Davis Street.

I. Five Hundred

Evanston, Illinois · summer 1895

That was the summer everybody in Evanston got on a wheel. The professors at the University rode, and the students, and the young ministers from the Biblical Institute rode in their black coats with their trousers clipped at the ankle. The Methodist ladies rode, in divided skirts their mothers would not have let in the house. Men who went in to the city on the Northwestern every morning came home at six and changed and were out again by seven, ringing their bells along Chicago Avenue under the elms, and the whole long town by the lake smelled of rubber cement and machine oil and cut grass, and every porch had a bicycle leaning on it, and every stable that had lost its horse had a bicycle in the stall.

Most of them had learned from Madame.

She had taken the old roller rink on Sherman Avenue in the spring of 1893 and painted Riding Academy over the door, and she kept a ledger of her pupils, name and date and the number of lessons it had taken, in a column as straight as a fence. By the end of June 1895 the ledger had five hundred names in it. Her own name was Odile Lacasse. She came from a parish on the river below Montreal, and in the eighties, when the wheels were high and only acrobats and young men rode them, she had raced for

money, women against women and sometimes against men and once against a trotting horse, in halls in Chicago and Minneapolis and Cincinnati. She had ridden seven hundred and some miles in a single week on a board track in a hall on the lake front, round and round, from noon Monday to midnight Saturday, with a brass band playing and the crowd going home and coming back, and had never once gone out the door. She was near forty now. A fall in Cincinnati had left her with a hip that ached in wet weather, and she walked with a little hitch, but on a wheel there was nothing wrong with her at all.

Her pupils had made themselves into a club. They called it the Davis Street Wheel Club because they met in the evenings at the fountain at the foot of Davis Street, and by July there were forty of them, and on Saturdays they rode out together, north along the lake or west to the Ridge, in a long line with the captain in front, and in the evenings they sat on the rim of the fountain with their wheels leaning against it and talked about the roads.

The captain was Elmer Tuthill, who wrote fire insurance in the Rookery building and kept the club's road book. It was the League's book for the state, bound in red cloth, and he had written in the margins of it in pencil until there was hardly any margin left. Sheridan Road was macadam to the Ravines and then it was not. Ridge Avenue was good in dry weather and gumbo in wet. The road out past Gross Point was sand from the beach, and you walked it. The way to Niles Center was pebbles, and the way to Glenview had no pebbles, but it had a hill. The plank road to Wheeling had rotted, and there was a farm dog at the second bridge. They argued over it the way their grandfathers had argued over the meaning of baptism, and sometimes Tuthill would say a road was bad and Dr. Pruyn the dentist would say it was fair, and it would go on until the lamplighter came.

Madame was not there for any of this. At the end of June she had taken her wheel and a valise strapped over the back of it and gone up into Wisconsin to teach the summer people at the lake resorts, and she was gone all of July and August.

II. The Fountain

Davis Street · September 1895

She came home on the first Monday in September, riding in from the north at sundown, brown as a farmhand, with the dust of four counties on her shoes, and she got off at the fountain because there was a crowd at it and she knew every face in the crowd.

They were talking about the road to Lake Forest. Tuthill had the book open on his knee. Mrs. Bascom, who was the club's secretary and the head of the Temperance Union in the Second Ward, had come back from it that afternoon and said it was a disgrace, that the stretch through Highland Park was nothing but pebbles the size of hens' eggs, and that a lady could not enjoy herself for one minute on it, and Tuthill had written *pebbles, H. P.* in the margin and underlined it, and Dr. Pruyn was saying that he had been over it in July and it was not as bad as all that.

Madame stood holding her wheel and listened to them for a while. Nobody had seen her yet. Then somebody did, and they all got up and shook her hand, and somebody gave her the place on the rim of the fountain, and she sat down.

What were you all talking about, she said, *when I came?*

They told her. The road to Lake Forest. The pebbles in Highland Park. The sand at Gross Point, the farm dog at the bridge.

All summer?

Tuthill laughed and held up the road book, and the pencil in the margins was so thick it shone.

Mrs. Bascom said that Miss Willard herself agreed about pebbles. She had the new book in her bag, Miss Willard's book about learning the wheel, which had come out that spring and which half of Evanston had read because Miss Willard was an Evanston woman, and she found the place and read it out to settle the matter.

> *Another thing I found is that we carry in the mind a picture of the road; and if it is humpy by reason of pebbles, even if we steer clear of them, we can by no means skim along as happily as when its smoothness facilitates the pleasing impression on the retina; indeed, the whole science and practice of the bicycle is "in your eye" and in your will; the rest is mere manipulation.*
>
> *— Frances E. Willard, A Wheel Within a Wheel (1895)*

There, said Mrs. Bascom. *Pebbles.*

Madame held out her hand for the book and read the passage again to herself, moving her lips, because she read English slowly. Then she gave it back.

Read the end again.

Mrs. Bascom read it again. *In your eye and in your will. The rest is mere manipulation.*

Bon, said Madame. *She has it.* She looked around at all of them on the rim of the fountain, forty people she had held up by the saddle on the floor of a roller rink, one at a time, until they could go. *I rode seven hundred miles in a week once in a hall on the lake front. There was no road. There were boards, and the same corner every half a minute, and a man with a cornet. And I went seven hundred miles.* She tapped the side of her eye with one finger. *The road is in here. All summer you are carrying the pebbles in here. In Highland Park they are only on the road, they are only pebbles. In here they are with you the whole way home.*

Nobody said anything. Tuthill closed the road book on his finger.

Saturday, said Madame, *I will ride with you. We go to Gross Point. The sand.*

III. The Nail

North of Evanston · the next Saturday

Twenty-six of them went. They rode out in a line in the cool of the morning, Madame at the head where Tuthill usually rode, and Tuthill behind her, with the road book in his coat. North of town the

MACADAM GAVE OUT AND THE ROAD TURNED TO SAND, DEEP and yellow and loose, the kind of road the book said you walked, and at the edge of it the line slowed and bunched up and people began putting a foot down.

Madame did not stop. She called back over her shoulder, not loudly, *Look up. Look at the steeple. Not at the road. The steeple,* and they looked up at the spire of the church at Gross Point a mile off across the fields, and pushed. The wheels squirmed and wandered and somehow went on, with the sand hissing under the tires. Mrs. Bascom said afterward that it was like riding through sugar, and that she had not once thought about the sand until she was on the far side of it.

On the far side Tuthill's back tire went down with a sigh.

They all got off and stood around it. Madame laid the wheel on its side in the grass and ran her thumb around the tire until she found it, and pulled it out and held it up for them to see: a horseshoe nail, bent, black, an inch and a half long. Every farm road in Cook County was sown with them.

That, she said, *is what hurts. Not the sand. Something small that gets in and stays in.* She dropped the nail in Tuthill's hand. Then she took the little tin of cement and the patches out of her own tool bag and held them out to him too.

Tuthill looked at the tin. *Madame, you could do that in two minutes.*

Yes, she said. *You do it.*

It took him twenty minutes, with the whole club giving advice, and his cuffs were black to the wrist when he was done, and the patch held all the way home.

IV. Let Go

Hinman Avenue · September 1895

MRS. ABIGAIL CRANE WAS SIXTY-SIX YEARS OLD, THE WIDOW OF a professor at the Biblical Institute, and she was the only member of the Davis Street Wheel Club who could not ride. She had joined in June because her daughters were in it. All summer one of the men from the club

HAD COME BY HER HOUSE IN THE EVENINGS TO RUN BESIDE HER on the sidewalk with a hand on the back of her saddle, and she would pedal very straight to the corner, talking the whole time, and at the corner she would say, *You have me, Mr. Tuthill?* and Mr. Tuthill would say, *I have you, Mrs. Crane,* and the moment he let go she would feel it, and stop, and put her foot down.

On the last evening of September Madame came instead.

She held the saddle and ran, with her hitch, and Mrs. Crane pedaled and talked. She talked about her late husband, who had been against bicycles on principle. She talked about her daughters, and about Miss Willard, whom she had known when Miss Willard was a girl, and about the book, which she had read twice, and about the line in it that everybody in Evanston was saying that fall.

> *"Let go, but stand by"—this is the golden rule for parent and pastor, teacher and friend; the only rule that at once respects the individuality of another and yet adds one's own, so far as may be, to another's momentum in the struggle of life.*
>
> *— Frances E. Willard, A Wheel Within a Wheel (1895)*

Look up, said Madame. *At the end of the street. Where the lamps are.*

Mrs. Crane looked up the street. The lamps were just being lit, one after another, far up Hinman Avenue under the elms.

You have me? she said.

I am here, said Madame, and let go, and stopped running, and stood in the road.

Mrs. Crane went on. She went on past the corner, still talking, and past the next house and the next, pedaling very straight, with her eyes on the lamps, and her voice came back fainter and fainter down the avenue, telling Madame something about Miss Willard as a girl that nobody else would ever hear.

That was the last week the club talked about roads. In October the rains came, and somebody found the road book left on the rim of the fountain at the foot of Davis Street, swollen with water, its red cloth gone

pink, the pencil in its margins running grey into the pages, and carried it in to Tuthill at the Rookery, and he thanked them, and put it in a drawer, and did not take it out again.

Background

The verses

> *The best of ways is the eightfold; the best of truths the four words; the best of virtues passionlessness; the best of men he who has eyes to see.*
>
> Dhammapada 273, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *This is the way, there is no other that leads to the purifying of intelligence. Go on this way! Everything else is the deceit of Mara (the tempter).*
>
> Dhammapada 274, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If you go on this way, you will make an end of pain! The way was preached by me, when I had understood the removal of the thorns (in the flesh).*
>
> Dhammapada 275, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *You yourself must make an effort. The Tathagatas (Buddhas) are only preachers. The thoughtful who enter the way are freed from the bondage of Mara.*
>
> Dhammapada 276, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha comes back to Sāvatthī from a journey through the country and finds five hundred monks in the assembly hall talking about the roads they have walked: the road to this village is smooth, to that one rough, this one is covered with pebbles, that one has none. He asks what they are discussing, tells them that such roads are no concern of a monk, who should give himself to the Noble Path, and speaks these verses on the Noble Eightfold Path, which opens the Path chapter of the Dhammapada. At the end of the teaching all five hundred become arahants. Read the full commentary story.

Evanston, Illinois

Evanston, 1895

The "safety" bicycle, with two wheels of equal size and pneumatic tires, set off a bicycle boom in the 1890s that put millions of Americans, women among them, on wheels; the League of American Wheelmen, which reached 103,000 members in 1898, led the Good Roads movement, and its state divisions published road books for cyclists. Before the safety, racing was done on high-wheelers, and a few women raced professionally in multi-day indoor contests; the Canadian Louise Armaindo held a record of 843 miles in one such race in 1886. Evanston, on the lake just north of Chicago, was founded by Methodists, dry by law from 1858, and grew as a railroad commuter suburb around Northwestern University and the Garrett Biblical Institute, and the lakeshore Sheridan Road, named in 1889, was being laid out through the North Shore in those years.

Evanston was also the home of Frances E. Willard, president of the Woman's Christian Temperance Union, who at fifty-three learned to ride a bicycle she named Gladys and described it in *A Wheel Within a Wheel: How I Learned to Ride the Bicycle* (Fleming H. Revell, 1895). She took lessons from a young Evanston schoolteacher and in a riding gallery in Chicago, and learned the rest in England with trainers who held the machine until she could tell them, "Let go, but stand by." Madame Lacasse, Mrs. Crane and the Davis Street Wheel Club are fictional.

After the story of the five hundred bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 273–276). The original. Scripture from Frances E. Willard, *A Wheel Within a Wheel* (1895). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.2

Twenty Thousand Days

Coming, they go; and then is best,
When each has ceased, and all is rest!
— Buddhist Suttas, Introduction

This is how I heard it told, on the yard at Eddyville.

I. The Castle

Kentucky State Penitentiary, Old Eddyville · November 2000

The penitentiary stands on the bank of the Cumberland where it widens into Lake Barkley, a fortress of yellow-gray limestone with towers at the corners and battlements along the top, put up in the 1880s by Italian stonemasons out of rock quarried down the river. The men call it the Castle. When the Corps of Engineers dammed the river in the 1960s and raised the water, they moved the whole town of Eddyville up the road onto higher ground, the courthouse and the churches and the stores and every house that would go on a truck, and what would not go on a truck went under the lake. The prison stayed where it was. It was the one thing in Old Eddyville that nobody thought of moving.

On the second Saturday of every month, a Sri Lankan monk named Bhante Piyaratana drove up from Nashville to meet with the Buddhists. There were four of them that year. They met in a side room off the chapel, with a steel table pushed against the wall and plastic chairs in a circle, and a correctional officer named Darla Mize sitting by the door, as one always had to, with her radio turned down low.

Bhante was sixty-eight. He had come from a village outside Kandy in 1989 to look after a small temple in a brick house in Antioch, south of Nashville, for families who worked at the hospitals and at Vanderbilt, and

he had been coming to Eddyville since 1997, when a man there wrote to the temple. That man had made parole and gone. The four who were left had all come after. He drove a 1988 Buick that a dentist's widow had given the temple, two hours up the interstate, in his robe and a gray cardigan and a knit cap, and he carried a book bag with a bell in it and two Styrofoam cups from the temple kitchen, and nothing else, because nothing else was allowed.

A year before, he had taught them to sit. He had given them the breath, in and out, to watch at the tip of the nose, and he had given them the wish for the good of all beings, to say over to themselves at night. They had worked at it for a year as hard as any four men ever worked at anything.

Raymond Tolbert, who was from the West End of Louisville and had been down since 1984, sat on his bunk every night from ten until the eleven o'clock count, cross-legged, with a towel over his knees, and when the count was cleared sat again until one. Lonnie Gish, from Clover Fork in Harlan County, the oldest of them, tried every night and fell asleep every night, sitting up, and woke at the count with his chin on his chest. Curtis Wyatt, who had grown up in Lyon County within sight of the towers and used to fish below the walls with his uncle, found that when he watched his breath he got angrier than he had been in years, and he went to the hole twice that spring for things he said. The youngest, Anthony Briggs, who was twenty-three and had been there two years, quit in June and came back in August without explaining.

On the second Saturday in November, Bhante came in and set the bell on the steel table and asked how it was going, the way he always asked, and Raymond, who never said anything first, said it.

It ain't working, Bhante. We been doing it a year. We need something else.

II. The Count

The side room off the chapel

Bhante did not answer him. He closed his eyes and sat with his hands folded in his lap, for so long that Anthony looked at

Curtis and Curtis shrugged, and Officer Mize looked up from her radio. The furnace came on somewhere in the walls. It was about four minutes. Then Bhante opened his eyes and asked them a question that did not seem to have anything to do with it.

How long have you been here?

None of them had to think. That is a thing about men who are doing life. Lonnie said, *Ten thousand one hundred and twenty-nine days.* Raymond said, *Fifty-eight hundred and forty.* Curtis said, *Thirty-five hundred and ten.* Anthony said, *Seven hundred and twelve.*

Bhante looked at Officer Mize. She had been at the Castle nineteen years and had never once said anything in the Buddhist meeting, and she did not intend to, and she heard herself say, *I don't count mine that way. I count what's left. Two thousand and forty, till I can draw my pension.* The men laughed. She did not mind.

Bhante took a request slip out of his book bag and the stub of a pencil and added up the four numbers, slowly, carrying with his lips moving, and turned the slip around on the table so they could see it. It said 20,191.

Twenty thousand days, he said. *You have been practicing this a long time. Longer than me.*

Practicing what?

He asked Lonnie whether he still kept the calendars. Everybody in the room knew Lonnie kept the calendars. He had kept one on the wall of every cell since February 1973, the free kind from a feed store or a funeral home, and every night before the count he put an X on that day with a pencil, and on the first of January he took the old calendar down and put it in his footlocker with the others. There were twenty-seven of them.

When you put the X on the day, said Bhante, *where is the day?*

Lonnie thought. *Gone.*

In twenty-seven years, did one day stay?

No, sir.

Not one. Good. Bhante put the pencil down on the slip. *This is the whole practice. You know it already better than I know it. Now do the same with the breath. It comes. X. It is gone. Do it with the sounds. Somebody shouts on the*

tier. X. Gone. Do it with the thoughts. Do it with anything that comes up. Every one, X. Don't try to make anything stay. Just watch whether one stays.

Then he rang the bell once, and while it was still sounding he chanted something in Pali, a short verse, three times through. Raymond asked him what it was. Bhante said it was what the monks chant at every funeral in Sri Lanka, standing at the grave, holding one end of a long white cloth while the other end lies on the coffin, and that he had chanted it over his own father and mother and over more people in Nashville than he could count. He said there was an Englishman, a civil servant in Ceylon in the old days, who had put it into English a hundred and twenty years ago in the introduction to a book of the old sermons, describing a funeral in Ceylon, and he had found it in the Vanderbilt library and copied it out, and he said it to them now in English, standing up, from memory.

> *How transient are all component things!*
> *Their nature's to be born and die;*
> *Coming, they go; and then is best,*
> *When each has ceased, and all is rest!*
>
> *— Buddhist Suttas, Introduction*

Curtis said, *That's it?*

That's it, said Bhante, and picked up his book bag, because the officer was standing and it was time.

III. Eleven O'Clock

The cellhouse · that night

The televisions in the dayroom had been on Florida for four days, men in suits holding ballots up to the light, a recount, and then another count of the recount. Lonnie went past without looking.

At a quarter to eleven he put the X on the eleventh of November with the pencil and sat down on the bunk with his back to the wall and his hands on his knees. He did not try to watch the breath at the tip of his

nose. He watched it go. It came in, and he let it come in, and when it went out he put an X on it. It was gone. The next one came. X.

A man two cells down was shouting at somebody about a radio. X. It was gone, and another shout came, and that was gone. The pipes knocked. Gone. The officer's keys came down the tier for the count and passed his door and went on, and the sound of them got smaller and stopped. His knee hurt. X. It hurt again, a new hurt, and that one went too. He had been counting days for twenty-seven years without once noticing what he was looking at, and now he was looking at it, and it was everything. Nothing stayed. Not one thing in the cellhouse stayed, not the light on the ceiling, not the voices, not the smell of the floor wax, not Lonnie.

Then the bar in Evarts came up, the way it came up most nights, the way it had come up nearly every night since February 1973: the jukebox, the cue in his hand, the man's face, the way the man went down and did not get up. It came up whole, as it always did, and he waited for it to stay the way it always stayed, all night.

It went. He saw it go. It had come and it had gone, like the shout and the keys. It came up again, and that was a new one, and it went too. He had thought for twenty-seven years that it was one thing he carried, and it had never been one thing. It had been a thousand thousand things, each one coming up and ceasing, and he had been picking up every one of them and holding it, and he was so tired. Something in him got tired of it then, the way a hand gets tired, and opened.

He sat on the bunk until the two o'clock count without moving, and the officer looked at him through the bars and went on.

• • •

It went the same way with the others, though none of them ever said much about it, and none of them on the same night. Raymond on the yard on Monday morning stood by the fence in the cold and laughed out loud at nothing anybody could see, and when Curtis asked him what was funny he said, *It keeps going.* Curtis himself did not go to the hole again,

the rest of the time he was at the Castle. Anthony, the youngest, said it happened to him in the shower, of all places, with the water.

Officer Mize, who had only been sitting by the door, noticed on the Monday that she had come to work without looking at the little calendar in her lunchbox where she kept her number. She did not look at it on Tuesday either. She kept it in the lunchbox until she retired, five years and some months later, and she never did put another mark in it.

IV. Winter Pool

The side room, and the road home · December

In December Lonnie asked Bhante if there was a thing the monks did for the dead, besides the verse. He said the man's name. He had not said it out loud since his trial.

Bhante took the two Styrofoam cups out of his book bag and set one on the steel table and filled the other at the water fountain in the hall, with Officer Mize's permission. He held the full cup over the empty one and said that at home, at the grave, they pour water from one vessel into another until it fills and runs over, for the dead, so that what is given here reaches them there. He began to pour, slowly, and chanted while he poured, and the water rose in the lower cup and reached the brim and ran over onto the table and down the steel leg to the floor tiles, and he went on pouring until the upper cup was empty. Then he said the English, which was in the same old book, just after the other.

> *As water poured on mountain tops*
> *Must soon descend, and reach the plain;*
> *So surely what is given here*
> *Will reach and bless the spirits there!*
>
> *— Buddhist Suttas, Introduction*

Lonnie looked at the water on the floor for a while.

That river out there, he said, *starts on Clover Fork. Three forks come together at Baxter, below Harlan, and that's the start of the Cumberland. He was from*

Baxter. He did not say anything else. Officer Mize went and got paper towels, and she and Lonnie wiped up the floor together.

• • •

Bhante drove home the long way that afternoon, down the lake road past Kuttawa, because he liked to see the water. It was the second week of December and the Corps had let the lake down to its winter level, and in the shallow bays the old towns came up a little way out of it, the way they did every winter. Pieces of brick foundation. Rows of stumps that had been telephone poles. Where the road bent along the shore, he could see a stretch of the old highway coming up out of the gray water onto the mud, a straight piece of pavement with the center line still on it, faded almost to nothing. It ran up out of the lake for fifty yards and stopped. He pulled over in the Buick and looked at it for a while with the engine running. A man in a duck boat was going by out on the open water, and the wake came in and went over the end of the road, and drew back, and the line was still there.

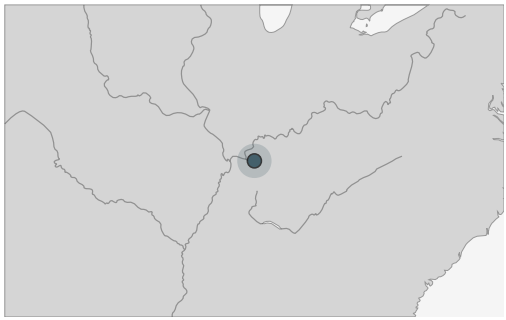
Background

The verse

> *'All created things perish,' he who knows and sees this becomes passive in pain; this is the way to purity.*
>
> Dhammapada 277, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred monks take a meditation subject from the Buddha into the forest and strive with all their might, but cannot reach arahantship, so they come back to ask for a subject better suited to them. The Buddha considers, and sees that in the time of the previous Buddha, Kassapa, these same monks had spent twenty thousand years meditating on impermanence. So he gives them a single verse on impermanence, and at the end of it they are all established in arahantship. Read the full commentary story, or about impermanence in Buddhist teaching. The verse Bhante chants, *Aniccā vata saṅkhārā*, is said in the Mahāparinibbāna Sutta to have been spoken at the Buddha's death and is still chanted at Theravada funerals. Both English renderings in the story come from T. W. Rhys Davids's introduction to

Buddhist Suttas (Sacred Books of the East 11, 1881), where he describes a funeral in Ceylon: the white cloth held between the monks and the coffin, and water poured into a cup until it overflows.



Old Eddyville, Kentucky

Eddyville, 2000

The Kentucky State Penitentiary, the "Castle on the Cumberland," was built of limestone blocks by Italian stonemasons and opened in 1890; it is the state's oldest prison and its maximum-security institution. When Lake Barkley was impounded behind Barkley Dam in 1966, the towns of Eddyville and Kuttawa were moved to new sites, and what was left by the water became Old Eddyville and Old Kuttawa. Each fall the Corps of Engineers draws the lake down to winter pool, and old roads, foundations and pavement come up out of the water.

The Cumberland River begins where its Poor, Clover and Martins forks meet at Baxter in Harlan County, flows west through Nashville, and returns to Kentucky through Lake Barkley on its way to the Ohio. In November and December 2000, while the story takes place, the presidential election hung on the Florida recount.

After the story of the Characteristic of Impermanence from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 277). The original. Scripture from T. W. Rhys Davids, *Buddhist Suttas*, Sacred Books of the East 11 (1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.3

Twelve Stacks

> *Union with the unpleasant is painful, painful is separation from the pleasant.*
> *— Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta 5, tr. T. W. Rhys Davids (1881)*

The way I heard it, down on Eighth Avenue.

I. The Ad

Munhall, Pennsylvania · February 2007

Dottie found it in the Sunday paper between the obituaries and a coupon for Lenten fish sticks, and she read it to him across the kitchen table the way she read him the obituaries, slowly, in case he knew somebody. *Do you have pain in your low back nearly every day? Are you sixty-five or older? Researchers at the university are looking for volunteers for a study of an eight-week program.* There was a number. There was a little drawing of a man holding the small of his back, and Joe Pavlik said the man in the drawing looked like he had never lifted anything heavier than a briefcase in his life.

It's free, Dottie said. *They give you a gift card.*

Joe had run a soaking-pit crane at the Homestead Works for twenty-three years. The ingots came over from the open hearth still dark on the outside and molten in the middle, and they stood in the pits under the lids until the heat had gone all the way through them evenly, and then Joe's crane came over and the tongs went down into the glare and lifted them out, white, one at a time, and laid them on the buggy for the forty-five-inch mill. His back went in 1979 when a tong slipped and the whole cab bucked under him like a truck hitting a curb. He worked on it seven

more years, until there was nothing left to work at, and in 1986 the mill shut, and after that his back was the only part of the job he still had.

Now there was a shopping center where the mill had been, with a Loews and a Target and a Bed Bath & Beyond, and at the far end of the theater parking lot the developers had left twelve brick smokestacks standing in a row for history. They had been the stacks over the soaking pits. Three nights a week Joe drove a security cart around that parking lot in a blue jacket with a patch on it, and sometimes at two in the morning he parked under the stacks and looked up at them for a while, the way you'd look at a team photograph.

He called the number on Monday. The girl who answered said they had gotten more than five hundred calls. She asked him a great many questions, among them what year it was and who the president was, and whether he could count backward from a hundred by sevens, which he could, faster than she could check it. Two weeks later a computer flipped a coin for him. He got the class.

Earl Mosley, who had worked the labor gang at the forty-five-inch mill and who sat two tables over from the Pavliks at the Slovak church's fish fry every Friday in Lent because the fish was better there than at his own church, called the same number and got the waiting list. *Story of my life,* Earl said. *I been on a waiting list since 1986.*

II. The Raisin

Upstairs at the Carnegie library · the first Tuesday in March

The class met in a room upstairs at the Carnegie library on the hill, which Mr. Carnegie had built for the workingmen of Homestead six years after his company brought the Pinkertons up the river against them. The room smelled faintly of chlorine from the pool. There were eighteen of them on folding chairs in a circle, and a stack of blue foam mats against the wall that most of them looked at with suspicion.

The teacher was a short woman with gray hair cut like a boy's and a man's steel watch, and Joe knew her before she said her name. Rose

Kuhar. She had hired into the mill in the fall of 1977, one of the women the company had started taking on, and they had put her on the labor gang in the forty-five-inch mill shoveling scale out from under the rolls. The men had given her the business for a year and a half. Joe had not been one of the worst of them. He had not been one of the ones who stopped it, either.

She went around the circle and had them each say their name and where it hurt. A retired schoolteacher from West Homestead named Helen Sabol. Gary Rusnak, who had a piece of a Chinese mortar round still in his hip from 1968 and had driven a beer truck for thirty years on top of it. A Westinghouse engineer from Turtle Creek who wanted to know how the data would be analyzed. A woman who had raised seven children in a three-room half of a double house in Rankin and said only that it was everything, honey, it was the whole thing. Joe said his name and his low back. Rose looked at him a second longer than she looked at the others.

Number four crane, she said.

That's right.

Then she went around with a box of Sun-Maid raisins and a spoon and put one raisin in each of their palms, and asked them to look at it as if they had never seen a raisin before, as if they had just come down from another planet and this was the first one. Gary Rusnak said, *It's a raisin, Rose.* She said, *Look anyhow.*

Joe looked. It was wrinkled and dark and a little sticky and it had a pale scar on one end where it had been pulled off its stem. Turned in the light from the window, it was a deep red brown, like the skin of an ingot coming out of the pit before the air hit it and the scale came up. He had not expected that. He smelled it, as she told them to, and held it on his tongue, and bit it, and the taste was much larger than the raisin. Helen Sabol was writing in a notebook. The engineer had eaten his before she told them to and was looking around for another one.

At the end she handed out compact discs with BODY SCAN written on them in marker. Forty-five minutes. Every day, six days out of seven. *You don't have to like it,* she said. *You just have to do it.*

III. The Calendars

Munhall · March and April

So Joe did it. He lay on the den carpet every morning after the coffee, with a bed pillow under his knees, and Rose's voice came out of Dottie's kitchen boom box and took him on a tour of himself. The toes of the left foot. The sole of the foot. The heel where it touched the floor. She went so slowly up the left leg that by the time she got to his knee he had planned out the whole week's errands, and some mornings he fell asleep somewhere around the pelvis and woke to her saying, kindly, that the scan was coming to an end now. Dottie stepped over him on her way to the sewing machine. When Rose got to the low back, he would breathe into it the way she said to, and wait for it to let go.

It did not let go. Nobody had said it would. Rose had said, the first night, that they were not trying to get anywhere. But a man does not lie on his floor forty-five minutes a day for nothing, and Joe, who had never once in twenty-three years left a pit lid open or set an ingot down crooked, did it every morning, six out of seven, and checked the box on the sheet.

The second week Rose gave them a calendar, a sheet with seven rows for one pleasant thing each day. What was the event. Were you aware of it while it was happening. What did your body feel. What were you thinking. What do you feel now, writing it down. Joe wrote: *Fish fry. Pierogies. Earl told the one about the priest and the crane.* Body: *Warm. Full.* Thinking: *Wish it was Friday every day.* He wrote: *Danny called from Charlotte, put the baby on.* Body: *Tight in the chest. Throat.* Thinking: *Don't hang up yet.*

The third week she gave them a second calendar for the unpleasant things, and Joe filled that one in faster. *Back. Ice in the theater lot. Back. Gas, $2.59. Back. Danny didn't call.*

The weeks went by. They learned to sit in their chairs and follow the breath in and out of the nose. They walked very slowly in a line around the room upstairs at the library, lifting, moving, placing, the engineer counting under his breath, and people coming out of the pool downstairs in their bathing caps looked up the staircase at them and kept going.

Helen Sabol did the body scan twice a day and color-coded her calendars. Gary Rusnak bought a second CD player for the truck. The woman from Rankin fell asleep at every single body scan and snored, softly, and nobody had the heart to wake her.

At the start of each class Rose asked how it was going, and they told her. Joe's back was a six. It had been a six in February, on the girl's form, and it was a six on Easter Sunday, kneeling, and a six on the Tuesday after.

IV. Number Four Crane

Upstairs at the Carnegie library · the last Tuesday in April

THE EIGHTH CLASS WAS THE LAST ONE. THE GIRL FROM THE university, whose name was Megan and who was writing a dissertation, was coming at eight o'clock with the forms. Before she came Gary Rusnak cleared his throat and said what all of them had been saying in the parking lot.

Rose, with respect. I been lying on that floor eight weeks. I did every one. My hip's the same as when I walked in here. Helen's the same. We're all the same. He looked around the circle and they nodded. *We gave it a fair shake. Maybe this thing works for those people up in Massachusetts. Is there something else? Something more for people like us?*

Rose did not answer him right away. She looked around the circle at them one at a time, the way she had looked at Joe the first night, and later every one of them said the same thing, that she seemed to be looking at something a long way behind them. The engineer said it was like being looked at by somebody reading an old drawing.

Then she asked each of them what they had done for work. They told her. Thirty-four years at the Westinghouse in East Pittsburgh. Twenty-nine years of nights on a ward at Braddock General, lifting people. A coal patch in Fayette County, then the Duquesne Works, then a parking garage downtown. Seven kids. A beer truck. Number four crane.

Add it up, she said to the engineer.

He added it on the back of a sign-in sheet. Between the eighteen of them it came to something over five hundred years of work, and he checked it twice, and then, because he could not help it, he figured it in days, which was most of two hundred thousand.

You people have been practicing a lot longer than me, Rose said. *I gave you the wrong thing. I gave you the beginner thing. Take out your calendars.*

They had them in their folders. She had them lay the pleasant one and the unpleasant one side by side on their knees and read down the column where it said *body*.

Joe read his. On the pleasant side: *Warm. Full. Tight in the chest. Throat.* On the other side: *Tight. Tight. Jaw. Tight.* He read the column that said *thinking*. *Wish it was Friday every day. Don't hang up yet.* And on the other side: *Wish it would quit. Wish he'd call.*

Around the circle people went quiet as they read. Helen Sabol had written, under lilacs by the garage: *Wanted them to last.* The woman from Rankin had written for her pleasant thing that her great-grandson had fallen asleep on her, and under body: *my arm went dead and I didn't want to move it.*

It's all under load, Rose said. *A crane is under load carrying an ingot. Sitting still, it's under load holding itself up. You've been lying on the floor waiting for the load to come off. You thought the good days were the ones with no load on. Look at your sheet.*

Nobody said anything. Then she took a card out of her wallet, an index card gone soft at the corners, and said she had copied this out of an old book on a retreat years ago, and she read it to them.

> *Now this, O Bhikkhus, is the noble truth concerning suffering. Birth is attended with pain, decay is painful, disease is painful, death is painful. Union with the unpleasant is painful, painful is separation from the pleasant; and any craving that is unsatisfied, that too is painful.*
>
> *— Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta 5, tr. T. W. Rhys Davids (1881)*

Who wrote that? said Gary Rusnak.

A fella in India, said Rose. *Lie down.*

They got down on the blue mats, those who could, and those who could not leaned back in their folding chairs, and she did not put on the disc. She talked them through it herself, faster than the recording, and stopped longer at the parts that hurt. Joe lay on the floor and felt his back. It was a six. It was the same six. He felt the wanting it to be a five come up beside it, which he had never noticed, the way you never notice the hum of a motor until it stops, and he felt that the wanting was its own weight, a second ingot hung on the same tongs. He thought of Danny's baby on the phone. Tight in the chest. That was the same load too. It had all been the same load, the good days and the bad ones, the pierogies and the ice, and he had been carrying it with both hands for twenty-eight years and checking a box.

Something in him got tired of it. It felt like the end of a shift, when you have done everything you can do and the next man is climbing the ladder to the cab, and your hands come off the levers by themselves.

He laughed out loud on the floor. He could not help it. Across the room Helen Sabol was crying without any noise, and Gary Rusnak was breathing like a man who had just set down a keg, and the woman from Rankin was, for the first time in eight weeks, entirely awake. People who were there say that all eighteen of them got up off that floor different. Some of them say it in church and some of them say it at the Eat'n Park, and none of them has ever been able to say it very well.

Megan from the university was standing in the doorway with her clipboard against her chest. She had been there since the card. She was twenty-six, and her dissertation was due in fourteen months, and she had not slept through the night since Christmas. She stood with the forms against her and let her shoulders come down from around her ears, and did not know until later that she had done it.

Then she handed out the forms. Joe circled six for his back. Megan looked at it and at him.

Same as before?

Same, Joe said, and laughed again, and she wrote something in the margin.

V. The Lot

The Waterfront, Homestead · July

In June the computer's other half got its turn. Earl Mosley went every Tuesday night to the room upstairs at the library and came out complaining about the raisin. Joe drove him, because Earl's eyes were bad after dark, and sat in the car with the window down and listened to the swimmers.

The study came out the next year. On the whole the class had done somewhat better than the waiting list, the paper said, at managing their days, though the pain itself did not change much on either side. Dottie read it to him from the paper across the kitchen table, slowly, in case he knew somebody.

On a night in July Joe parked the security cart at the far end of the theater lot under the twelve stacks. The last show had let out. The sodium lights hummed. Up the hill the library was dark, and down past the stacks the Monongahela went by with a single string of barges on it, pushed by a towboat with one lit window. His back was a six. He sat with it the way you would sit beside a man you had worked with a long time, who did not need to be talked to.

Then he got down out of the cart, slowly, and put his palm flat on the asphalt over the place where the pits had been. It was midnight and the asphalt was still warm from the day, warm all the way through, the way an ingot is warm when it has soaked long enough and is ready to be lifted.

Background

The verse

> *`All created things are grief and pain,' he who knows and sees this becomes passive in pain; this is the way that leads to purity.*
>
> Dhammapada 278, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is very short, and it is the middle one of three alike. Five hundred monks receive a meditation subject from the Buddha, strive in the forest with all their strength, and do not reach awakening, so they come back to ask for a subject

better suited to them. The Buddha sees that in the time of an earlier Buddha, Kassapa, these same monks spent twenty thousand years contemplating suffering, so he gives them a single verse on that characteristic: everything conditioned, because it is oppressed, is suffering. At the end of it all five hundred are awakened, and everyone else who has gathered there benefits too. The ancient-buddhist-texts page for this story currently repeats the text of its twin, 20.2, word for word except for the verse; read the full commentary story, or about dukkha, the characteristic of suffering.

Homestead and Munhall, Pennsylvania

Homestead and the stress clinic, 2007

The Homestead Steel Works on the Monongahela, site of the 1892 lockout and battle with Pinkerton agents, employed some 15,000 people at its peak during the Second World War and closed in 1986. A shopping center, the Waterfront, opened on part of the site in 1999. Twelve brick smokestacks from the soaking pits of the 45-inch mill were left standing there, about 130 feet tall, at the edge of a movie-theater parking lot. Up the hill in Munhall, the Carnegie Library of Homestead, opened in 1898, still has its music hall and an athletic club with an indoor pool.

Mindfulness-based stress reduction began in 1979 at the University of Massachusetts Medical Center as an eight-week class for patients sent by their doctors for chronic pain and stress: guided body scans, sitting and walking meditation, gentle yoga, a first-night exercise with a single raisin, and calendars of pleasant and unpleasant events. In the 2000s it became the subject of many randomized trials, often with a wait-list control group that received the course afterward. The study in this story is invented, but its shape follows real ones, among them a University of Pittsburgh pilot trial begun in 2004 that taught an eight-week program in weekly 90-minute sessions to 37 adults aged 65 and older with chronic low back pain, recruited partly through newspaper ads (trial record; University Times report).

After the story of the characteristic of suffering from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 278). The original. Scripture from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta, tr. T. W. Rhys Davids, in *Buddhist Suttas* (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 11, 1881). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.4

The Mourner's Bench

> *I have been crucified with Christ; and it is no longer I that live, but Christ liveth in me.*
> *— Galatians 2:20 (American Standard Version, 1901)*

This is how it was testified, in the basement under Marsh Chapel.

I. The Bench

Pratt County, Kansas · the summers of 1947 to 1956

THE HOLINESS CAMP MEETING CAME EVERY AUGUST TO A grove of cottonwoods south of town, where there was a board tabernacle with a sawdust floor and open sides and, across the front of it below the pulpit, a long plank bench worn so smooth by knees and elbows that it shone like a gunstock. That was the mourner's bench. Vernon Albaugh's grandmother said twenty thousand souls had prayed through at that bench since the first camp in 1898, and she had been one of them, in 1911, in a white shirtwaist, and she had felt the old man die in her like a fire going out of a stove.

That was what you went forward for. The first time was to be saved, and Vern was saved at seven, easily, on a hot night with the moths batting around the gas lamps, and cried, and was glad. The second time was for the second blessing, entire sanctification, the death of self. You knelt at the bench and gave up the old man, the carnal nature, the I that wanted its own way, and you prayed until it died and the Holy Ghost came in and took its place. Grandma Albaugh said you would know. Her favorite hymn was *Not I, but Christ,* and she sang it at the stove and at the clothesline and once, in Vern's hearing, in the outhouse.

Vern went forward for the second blessing at nine. He knelt at the bench until the lamps were turned down and an evangelist from Oklahoma put a hand on his back and said, *Let it go, son, let it go,* and he did not know what *it* was or where it was kept. He went forward at ten and at eleven and every August after that. He prayed through the meetings and through the altar calls and once all night alone in the empty tabernacle with the crickets, gripping the bench until his hands hurt, and the old man would not die. It got bigger, if anything. It got very interested in whether it was dying.

At nineteen he went off to a Methodist college in Iowa, and from there, to the grief of his mother, who wrote every Sunday, to a seminary in Newton Centre, outside Boston, where the professors smoked pipes and did not believe in the second blessing as such. He did not either, he found, as such. But he still woke some nights in his room on the hill with his fists closed.

II. Four and Two

Boston University · Good Friday, April 20, 1962

THERE WERE TWENTY OF THEM, DIVINITY STUDENTS FROM around the city, who had signed up for a doctoral study a Harvard man was running on religious experience. They were divided into groups of four, and each four had two leaders. There would be a capsule. Half of the twenty would get a drug that came from a Mexican mushroom and half would get something else, and nobody, not the students and not the leaders, would know who had what. Then they would all go down to the small chapel in the basement of Marsh Chapel, on Commonwealth Avenue, and attend the Good Friday service being held upstairs by the dean of the chapel, which would come down to them over a loudspeaker.

Vern's four were himself and Hal Dunning, his roommate, a Congregationalist from Bangor who had signed up because Vern had, and two others he knew a little. One of their two leaders was a Harvard graduate student with a crew cut who was very kind and said almost nothing all day. The other was Mas Kitano.

Mas Kitano was thirty-four and a Methodist minister working on a degree at the School of Theology, and he was older than any of them in a way that had little to do with his age. He had been fourteen in the camp at Heart Mountain, in Wyoming, where his father kept the Japanese Methodist services in a mess hall and the wind blew sand under the doors. Mas had asked his four to meet with him beforehand, twice, so that on the morning itself nobody would be among strangers, and he had told them about the camp at the first meeting, when they went around the room. He had told them almost nothing else. At the second meeting, when Vern had told the group about the mourner's bench, more than he meant to, Mas had only looked at him for a long time, the way you look at a field to see what the weather has been doing to it.

On the morning itself, in a room off the basement chapel, Mas gave them their instructions. They were the same for everybody. *Whatever comes, go toward it. If something frightens you, look at it. Follow the service. Pray if you want to pray.* Vern wrote down *pray* in his head and underlined it.

The capsules came in small paper cups with water. Vern swallowed his like a man taking communion in a strange church, carefully, watching how the others did it.

III. The Pew

The basement chapel · the first hour

Hal went first. Twenty minutes in, his face began to redden from the collar up as if he were standing too near a stove, and he rubbed his neck and his forearms and looked at Vern with his eyes very wide and whispered, *It's starting.* His ears went crimson. He said everything was hot. Vern felt nothing at all and was ashamed of how much he envied him.

The service had begun upstairs. Through the grille of the loudspeaker came the organ, enormous and thinned at the same time, like music heard through a floor, and then a deep slow voice reading, and they could not always make out the words. Vern sat in the second pew with his

hands on the back of the pew in front of him and did as he had been told. He prayed. He followed the service. He prayed harder. He was a good student. He had been a good student at the mourner's bench too.

Some time later he noticed that the grain of the oak under his hands was moving. It ran along the pew back in long brown lines, and the lines were flowing very slowly, like water in a ditch, and when he took his eyes off them they went on flowing in the corner of his sight. He thought, quite calmly, *So it's this one,* and then the calm went out of him all at once.

What came next was the I that was watching the grain coming loose. He could feel it the way you feel a tooth going, a giving at the root, and he did what he had done every August since he was nine. He held on. He prayed for the old man to die and at the same time he held on to the old man with everything he had, because now that it was really going he was terrified of it going, and the more he held the bigger the terror got, until the basement chapel and the organ and the voice upstairs and Hal's red face were all very far down at the bottom of something, and he was hanging over it by his hands.

Across the room a student from another group stood up and walked out the side door, quickly, saying he had to tell them, and two leaders went after him into the street.

Vern's hands were locked on the pew back. He could not have opened them if the building had caught fire. Somebody was saying *I can't, I can't,* and it was him.

Mas, he said. *Mas. I can't do this one either. Give me something else.*

IV. No Longer I

The basement chapel · the second hour

Mas Kitano came and knelt on the floor in front of him, in the space between the pews, so that his face was a little below Vern's. He did not take Vern's hands off the pew. He looked at him for a long time, longer than he had looked at the second meeting, and Vern had the feeling, which he kept for the rest of his life and could never put better than this, that Mas was looking past him down a very long row of

PEOPLE KNEELING AT A VERY LONG BENCH, ALL THE WAY BACK, and every one of them was him.

You've been at this a long time, Mas said.

Since I was nine.

Longer than that. Mas was quiet a moment. *Vern. None of it is yours to hold. Not the old man. Not the new one. Not the being afraid. You can't keep it and you can't kill it. It was never yours.*

Then he said the verse. He said it plainly, the way you'd read a road sign to someone who had lost his glasses, from a little brown American Standard he had carried since the camp and did not need to open.

> *I have been crucified with Christ; and it is no longer I that live, but Christ liveth in me: and that life which I now live in the flesh I live in faith, the faith which is in the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself up for me.*
>
> *— Galatians 2:20 (American Standard Version, 1901)*

Vern had heard the verse a thousand times. Grandma Albaugh had cross-stitched the King James of it over the kitchen door. He heard now, for the first time, the small words in it, *no longer I,* and how little weight they put on anything.

His hands opened. He did not open them. They opened, and there was nobody hanging from them, and there was nothing to fall into. There was the organ through the grille, and the voice upstairs, and the oak grain running under his palms like water in a ditch, and Hal Dunning's red worried face, and Mas on his knees on the stone, and the smell of radiator dust and somebody's hair oil, and all of it was going on, all of it was entirely there, and there was no one in the middle of it it was happening to. He had been looking for the old man to die, and the old man had never had an address. He laughed, or something laughed. It was a very small laugh. It was like hearing a joke you had been told at nine and only now got.

He lived. That was the strange part, and the part he could not later make the questionnaires understand. He was still a man named Vernon

Albaugh, who had a sunburn line on his neck from Kansas that never went away, and who would be a little hungry when this was over, and who loved his grandmother, and none of that was in charge of anything. It went on the way the service went on upstairs, without needing him to hold it up.

Along the pew the other two of their four had gone very still, one with his face in his hands and the other looking up at the low ceiling of the basement as if it were open sky. Years later, when a young man came around with a tape recorder and a questionnaire, all four of them were found to have kept the day, each in his own way, and none of them could say it any better than Vern could.

How long it lasted he never knew. The voice on the loudspeaker came to the end of something and the organ came in under it, and in the second pew of the basement chapel Hal Dunning, whose face had gone back to its own color some while ago and who had had, he would always be fairly sure, nothing but a large dose of a vitamin, found that he was crying, with no idea why, and that he did not mind. He said afterward that he had sat through Good Friday services every year of his life and never once heard one.

V. Commonwealth Avenue

Afternoon

They came up out of the basement late in the afternoon into the ordinary light of Commonwealth Avenue, the four of them and their two leaders, and stood on the steps of the chapel while the traffic went by. The student who had walked out was back inside, sitting with a doctor. A girl in a raincoat went past with a bag of groceries and looked at them as if they were a little drunk, which they were, in a way, and Hal laughed and said good afternoon to her, and she said it back.

Mas Kitano shook each of their hands and said he would see them on Monday for the questionnaires. Vern asked him which he had gotten, the drug or the other. Mas said he did not know. He said he had stopped wanting to know, at about the same time Vern had.

Vern stood on the steps and looked at his hands. Across each palm were two deep red lines where the edge of the pew back had pressed into them all through the first hour, sharp as if they had been ruled there. He watched them. They were already going, the way the flush had gone out of Hal's face, filling in pink from the edges, softening, and he did not do anything about it. He stood on the steps with his hands open in front of him in the April light and let them fade.

Background

The verse

> *`All forms are unreal,' he who knows and sees this becomes passive in pain; this is the way that leads to purity.*
>
> Dhammapada 279, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

This is the third of three nearly identical commentary stories. Five hundred monks receive a meditation subject from the Buddha, strive hard in the forest without reaching awakening, and come back to ask for a subject better suited to them. Seeing that in the time of the earlier Buddha Kassapa they had spent twenty thousand years contemplating non-self, he tells them that the aggregates are not under our control and are without self, and speaks this verse; at its end all of them are awakened, and those gathered there benefit as well. Read the full commentary story, or about anattā, non-self.

Boston, Massachusetts

Marsh Chapel, Good Friday 1962

On Good Friday, April 20, 1962, Walter Pahnke, a Harvard graduate student working under Timothy Leary and the Harvard Psilocybin Project, ran what became known

as the Marsh Chapel Experiment, or the Good Friday Experiment. Twenty Protestant divinity students from the Boston area, divided into small groups with leaders, took capsules in a double-blind design: half received psilocybin, half a large dose of niacin, chosen because its flushing and tingling would make some of them think they had the drug. They then sat in a chapel in the basement of Boston University's Marsh Chapel while the Good Friday service led upstairs by its dean, Howard Thurman, was carried down to them by loudspeaker. Almost all of the psilocybin group reported profound religious experiences. One subject grew acutely anxious, left the chapel and went out along Commonwealth Avenue, and had to be brought back and sedated, a detail Pahnke's published account left out.

A follow-up a quarter century later by Rick Doblin found that most of the psilocybin subjects still counted the day among the high points of their spiritual lives, while most of the control group could remember few details of the service; Doblin also criticized the study's methods (MAPS archive of the study and follow-up). The mourner's bench, or altar, at the front of a camp-meeting tabernacle was central to the Holiness movement, which taught a second work of grace, entire sanctification, after conversion. All characters in this story are invented.

After the story of the characteristic of non-self from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 279). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.5

The Tin Horn

Shake off dull sloth, and joyful rise.
— Thomas Ken, "Awake, my soul, and with the sun"

As I heard it told, on the old meeting ground at Station Camp Creek.

I. Across the Creek

Sumner County, Tennessee · August 1802

Brother Josiah Oakes had come over the mountains from Botetourt County, Virginia, with an anvil in the bed of his wagon, and he had shod horses on Bledsoe's Creek for twenty years and preached on Sundays for nothing. He was sixty-eight that summer. He had a voice that had been ruined by smoke and did not carry, so at the meetings he let the younger men do the hollering from the stand, and he kept a tin horn instead, a long one, made by his own hands, which he blew to call the camp to preaching and to wake it at daylight. People said you could hear it at Gallatin. People said that about a good many things.

The meeting at Station Camp Creek that year ran four days, the second week of August, in a beech flat cleared out of the cane, with a stand of poles and boards at one end and split-log seats in rows on the ground before it. Families came forty miles in wagons and pitched by the creek. At night they built fires on platforms of logs packed with earth, so the trees overhead stood lit from beneath like the pillars of a house, and the preaching and the singing and the crying went on until two or three in the morning.

On the first evening Brother Oakes gathered the young men who had come seeking, and there were forty-one of them, and he gave each one a single verse of Scripture, out loud, one at a time, a different verse for

each, so that no two had the same. Then he sent them across the creek into the big woods on the far side.

Stay with that one, he told them. *Don't go looking for another. Stay with it till it opens.*

They went over the creek on the stepping stones, forty-one of them, in the last of the light.

Absalom Kittrell came back the first night. He was nineteen, the tallest of them, broad as a door, with a white scar that ran through his left eyebrow and into the lid. He had sat under a beech with his verse until it got dark and the whippoorwills started, and then he thought that he could pray as well lying in his father's wagon as sitting on a root, and better, and he waded back across in the dark and lay down in the wagon bed on the feed sacks and slept until the horn.

He meant to go back over in the morning. He meant to go back over at noon. He spent the second day helping his mother at the cook fire and the third watching the preaching, and he told himself he was getting religion as well where he was as anybody was getting it in the woods.

II. Coming Through

Station Camp Creek · the third evening

On the third evening, at about sundown, the singing started on the far side of the creek. It came out of the woods a long way off and got nearer, and the people at the stand stopped what they were doing and turned, and the forty came out of the trees and down to the water. They had not eaten in three days. Their shirts were torn by the cane and they had leaves in their hair, and they were singing a hymn that most of them could not have told you the words of the week before, and they came over the stepping stones singing it, and up through the camp to the stand.

Brother Oakes came down off the stand to meet them. He did not say anything at first. He went to each one, all down the line, and took him by both arms and looked into his face, and said his name, and the name of his verse, and then he held each one against his chest a moment, the way

you would hold a son come back from the Indian country, and let him go and went on to the next. It took a long time. Nobody at the stand minded. Women were crying. A man from the Presbyterian side began to pray out loud and then stopped, because there was no call for it.

Absalom stood at the edge of the crowd by the seats. Brother Oakes came down the line and passed within an arm's length of him on the way back up to the stand, and looked at him, and did not say anything to him at all.

On their way out of the woods the forty had come down past the spring on Nathan Hedge's place, two miles below the meeting ground, and Hedge's wife had come out with corn bread and buttermilk and stood at the spring while they ate. Hedge had asked them, every one, to come and take breakfast at his house in the morning before they scattered home. *Come at sunup,* he said. *She'll be killing chickens tonight.* So after the preaching they told Brother Oakes they would be gone early, at first light, to Hedge's, and would be back by the forenoon preaching.

Go on, then, the old man said. *Eat. You've earned it.*

III. The Night

The meeting ground · that night

Absalom lay in the wagon bed and could not sleep. Out there among the fires the forty were lying down where they could, wrapped in blankets, some of them still singing low. The old man had looked at every one of them and had not looked at him. He had held every one of them, and not him.

Then I'll come through tonight, he thought. *Tonight. And in the morning I'll go up to him, and he'll have to say my name.*

He got out of the wagon. He did not go back over the creek, because it was dark and the creek was a long way and it seemed to him that it was not the woods that mattered. He walked the meeting ground instead. He walked up between the rows of seats to the stand and back down to the fires and up again, saying his verse over, and then saying everything he could think of, and asking, and then demanding, and then asking again.

The exhorters gave out at two o'clock. The last of the singing stopped. The fires on the platforms burned down to beds of coals. He kept walking.

Toward morning he was so tired that he did not know which part of the ground he was on. He was walking with his eyes shut. He was asleep and walking. At the head of the rows, before the stand, the end of a split-log seat stuck out a foot past the others where somebody had cut it long, and he walked into it with his whole weight. It caught him above the knee and he went over it, and the bone of his thigh broke with a sound that people heard in their tents.

He screamed. He did not stop screaming.

The forty knew his voice, most of them; they had grown up with him. They came up out of their blankets and ran every way in the dark, falling over guy ropes and each other, until somebody got a pine knot lit at the coals and then another, and they found him lying in the leaves past the end of the seat with his leg bent where a leg does not bend. Two of them held his shoulders. One of the Hedge boys' cousins, who had seen it done to a horse, said they would have to pull it straight, and they pulled it straight while he screamed into a folded blanket, and somebody pulled two rails off the fence by the wagons, and they bound the leg between the rails with strips torn from their own shirts, which were torn already. Then they sat around him in the leaves holding the pine knots, and held his hands, and wiped his face, and talked to him, and would not leave him.

The pine knots burned down and the sky over the creek went gray and then yellow, and the light came down through the beeches, and they were still sitting there with him when Brother Oakes came out of his tent with the tin horn in his hand and put it to his mouth and blew the day in.

It was full sunup. Two miles down the creek Nathan Hedge's wife was taking chicken off the fire, and setting it at the back of the hearth to keep, and going to the door to look up the road.

IV. The Infare

The stand · the fourth morning

Brother Oakes came over and looked at the rails and the leg and the face of the boy, and knelt and put his hand on the boy's forehead, which was wet and cold. Then he looked around at the forty, and at the sun.

You boys didn't get to Hedge's.

No, sir. They told him how it had happened.

He was quiet a while. Then he said, *Well, that's twice.*

They waited, and he sat down on the end of the seat that had broken the boy's leg, as if it were any seat, and told them.

Eight winters back, when I kept the school on Bledsoe's Creek, I had a good many of you in it. You remember. In January I sent you all up the hollow for wood, and you went and cut and corded it like men, every one, but this one. This one found a big poplar that looked dead to him, and he thought, that'll be dry, I'll lie down and take my rest, and when they're done I'll climb up and break off what I need in a minute. And he spread his coat in the leaves and lay down and went to sleep and snored so you could hear him over the axes.

You found him on your way home, he said to the forty, *and you kicked him awake, I heard about it, and you went on and left him. And he jumped up and went up that poplar half asleep, and it wasn't dead. It was only bare. He took hold of a limb and pulled, and it was green and it bent and broke short and whipped back, and the end of it laid his eye open. And he came down with one hand over his eye and pulled green limbs off with the other, and tied them up, and came running down the hollow after you, and threw his green poplar on top of your good wood on the pile by my door.*

Absalom, on the ground, put his hand up to the scar.

That was the night before the Gwin infare, the old man said. *You recall. They had asked the whole school to the infare dinner, down at the Gwins', eleven miles, and I told you we would have to start at daylight, and you could not walk eleven miles in January on nothing, so my wife would get up and make mush. And she got up in the dark and went to the pile for wood, and the top of the pile was green poplar, and she laid her fire with it. And she blew on that fire.*

Keziah blew on that fire till her face was red. And it smoked and it hissed and it would not take, and the sun came up over the ridge, and you all stood in my kitchen and looked at it, and it was too late to go.

That boy, he said, not unkindly, *has kept you from your breakfast twice now.*

Some of the forty laughed, and then looked at Absalom and stopped. But Absalom was laughing too, on his back in the leaves, with the tears running out of the corners of his eyes into his ears, and it hurt him to laugh, and he did it anyway.

Then the old man said the thing he said, and he said it to all of them, but he was looking at the boy.

There's a time to rise, and it don't wait. A young man, strong, that won't get up when it's time, and lies there, and puts it off, and then tries to do it all at once in the dark, he won't ever find the way. Not in the woods and not on this ground. You can't pray three days in one night any more than you can dry green wood by blowing on it.

He looked at his horn a while, turning it in his big burned hands. Then, because his voice would not carry, he did not sing it; he said it, the morning hymn his mother had taught him in Botetourt, the one he blew the horn for.

> *Awake, my soul, and with the sun*
> *Thy daily stage of duty run;*
> *Shake off dull sloth, and joyful rise*
> *To pay thy morning sacrifice.*
>
> *— Thomas Ken, "Awake, my soul, and with the sun," stanza 1*

Then he got up off the seat, and took the axe from beside the stand, and cut the long end of the log off flush with the others, so it would not catch anybody else in the dark.

V. Daylight

Station Camp Creek · the morning after

They kept Absalom on the ground one more night, in the wagon bed on a tick of cane leaves, because he could not be moved yet over the roads. The meeting broke up around him. The families struck their camps and went off home in their wagons, and the forty went off with them, every one stopping at the wagon to say something to him, and the fires on the platforms went out and were not built up again.

In the night he did not sleep much, because of the leg. He lay and looked up through the beeches and said his verse over, the one the old man had given him on the first evening, which he had hardly looked at in four days. He did not say anything else. He just stayed with it.

Before light he heard the old man come out of his tent, the only tent left standing on the ground, and cough, and walk down toward the stand in the dark. Absalom raised himself on his elbows in the wagon bed. Over the creek there was no color yet. Then there was a little, a gray, behind the trunks of the beeches on the far side, and then a little yellow, and he was watching it come.

When the horn blew, for nobody but the two of them and the horses, he was already awake.

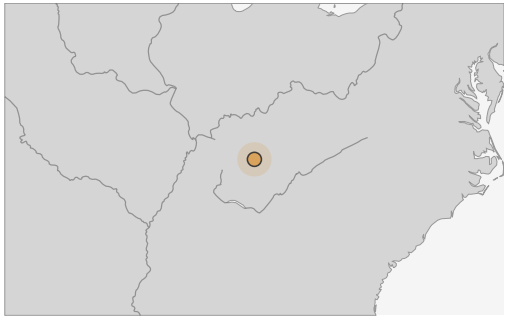
Background

The verse

> *He who does not rouse himself when it is time to rise, who, though young and strong, is full of sloth, whose will and thought are weak, that lazy and idle man will never find the way to knowledge.*
>
> Dhammapada 280, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred young men of Sāvatthī are ordained, take a meditation subject from the Buddha and go into the forest. One gives up at once; the rest become arahants. On their way back a lay follower feeds them and invites them to a meal the next morning. The Buddha welcomes the returning monks warmly and says nothing to the one who quit, who resolves to become an arahant that very night so

that the Buddha will speak to him. He walks up and down all night, falls asleep on his feet, trips over a stone seat at the end of the walkway and breaks his thigh, and the others spend the rest of the night tending him and miss the meal. The Buddha says the same monk once did this to them before, and tells the birth story of the Varuṇa tree (Jātaka 71): a lazy pupil sleeps through the wood-gathering, hurts his eye climbing a living tree he took for dead, and throws green wood on top of the others' bundles, so that the next morning the maid cannot light the fire for their early gruel and they miss a feast in the village. Read the full commentary story, which includes the birth story in full.



Sumner County, Tennessee

Camp meetings, 1800–1802

The camp meeting came out of the Great Revival on the southern frontier. James McGready's meeting at Gasper River in Logan County, Kentucky, in July 1800 is usually counted the first, and the Methodist John McGee held the first known Tennessee camp meeting that August at Drake's Creek in Sumner County, as the Tennessee Encyclopedia recounts. The next August, at Cane Ridge in Bourbon County, Kentucky, somewhere between ten and thirty thousand people gathered. Families came by wagon and camped for several days, usually four, in late summer; at Cane Ridge Presbyterian, Methodist and Baptist preachers all took part, and observers wrote of people falling, shouting and jerking under the preaching. Methodists would go on holding camp meetings for decades after others gave them up.

The hymn Brother Oakes says is the morning hymn of Thomas Ken (1637–1711), the English bishop who wrote it for the scholars of Winchester College; its last verse is the doxology still sung everywhere as "Praise God, from whom all blessings flow." The text here follows *The Otterbein Hymnal* (1890). An infare was the feast given at the groom's family's house after a wedding, an old custom of the upland South.

After the story of the Elder Padhānakammika Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 280). The original. Hymn by Thomas Ken, as printed in *The Otterbein Hymnal* (1890). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.6

The Dress Coat

> *Speak not but what may benefit others or yourself; avoid trifling conversation.*
> *— Benjamin Franklin, Autobiography*

The way I had it told, on the wharves at Ragged Harbor.

I. The Stair

Gull Ledge Light, outer Penobscot Bay, Maine · September 1904

At sunrise the keeper on watch put out the lamp, and the keeper coming on went up and helped him hang the linen curtains around the lens so the sun would not get into the glass and set the lantern afire, and then the two of them came down together. That was the rule at Gull Ledge, and it had been the rule longer than anybody now on the ledge had been there.

Ora Dyer came down first that morning, and Charlie Hupper behind him. Ora was first assistant, forty-four, an island man from Ragged Harbor who had fished until his back went. Charlie was nineteen and second assistant, which meant he did what the other two told him and shoveled coal for the fog whistle. There was a window halfway down the iron stair that looked out over the west end of the ledge where the weed was, at low water. Ora stopped at it. He looked out a long minute, and Charlie, on the step above, saw the side of his face change. He smiled.

It was not a thing Ora did much. Charlie leaned to see past him and saw the ledge and the weed and the tide going out.

What is it?

Not now, said Ora. *Ask me at supper, in front of Mr. Ames.*

II. Supper

The same evening

Josiah Ames had been head keeper at Gull Ledge since the fall before. He was a Ragged Harbor man too, sixty years old, a widower. He talked about as much as a gull post. What he did, besides keep the light, was birds. He had a book in which he wrote down every bird he saw on the ledge, the day and the hour and the wind, and every bird that came against the lantern at night and was picked up dead on the gallery in the morning, and once a year he sent a copy of it to a man at Washington who wrote him back a letter of thanks. The Lighthouse Board's library box came out on the tender every few months with fifty books in it, and when it came Ames took out whatever had to do with birds first and the Bible last, and generally read both.

When the plates were cleared, Charlie asked.

There was a man on the west end of the ledge, Ora said, *standing on the weed at low water. He had on a keeper's coat, the dress coat, with the buttons. He had a man's body and a man's hands. And he had the head of a hog. And out of the hog's mouth there came a tail, like a hog's tail only long, down to his knees, and maggots coming out the end of it and dropping off into the weed. That's what he was. I never saw such a thing as that. I smiled because I've heard there are such things, and I'd never seen one.*

Charlie laughed, and stopped, because nobody else did.

Josiah Ames put down his fork.

You've got eyes, Ora, and you use them, he said. *I've seen him. I saw him the morning after the big flight in May.*

He told Charlie about the flight, since Charlie had not come yet then. A night of south wind and thick weather, the twenty-second of May, and the birds going north over the bay in the dark by thousands, and the light pulling them in. All night they struck the glass. In the morning Ames went out on the gallery with a basket. There were warblers, yellow and black and chestnut, thrushes, a woodcock, two hundred and some birds, and a few still alive in the corners that he warmed in his shirt and let go. He picked up every one and laid them in rows to count them for the

book, and while he was doing it he looked down at the west end of the ledge.

I've seen him most low waters since, Ames said. *I didn't speak of it. People on the islands will laugh at a keeper who says he sees things, and it doesn't do them any good to laugh at a thing like that. I let it alone for their sake. Now there's two of us, so I'll tell who it is. It's Lyman Sprowl. Ora knows the name.*

Ora nodded. Charlie, who was from Rockland, did not know it.

III. Two Keepers

Gull Ledge · 1866–1886

Ansel Pote and Warren Crockett came onto Gull Ledge together in the spring of 1866, both of them out of the army. Ansel was keeper and Warren was his assistant, and they kept that light for twenty years. Ansel was one year older. In twenty years nobody on the islands heard either one say a hard word to the other. They lit the lamp together and put it out together. They wound the fog bell machinery in turns through every thick night, two hours on and two off, and wrote up the log in the same hand, near enough, so that the inspector once asked which of them had kept it. They had their Sundays. When the weather let them, one kept the light and the other rowed in to Ragged Harbor for meeting, and the next Sunday the other went. Both of them were bachelors. People said they were like a pair of oxen that had been yoked so long neither one knew which side he was on.

In 1884 the Board put the keepers into uniform: a double-breasted coat of navy blue with gilt buttons and a K on the collar for keeper, and a cap with a little lighthouse on the front. Ansel wore his on Sundays and when the inspector came. Warren carried it. From the first week that was how it was. When Ansel went in to meeting, Warren rowed him to the island and carried the dress coat down to the boat folded over his arm, and Ansel's dinner pail in the other hand, and held them on the wharf while Ansel climbed up. He would have carried Ansel up the ladder if Ansel had let him. Ansel did not ask it and did not stop it, and it was like that for two years.

IV. The Third Keeper

Gull Ledge · 1886

In the spring of 1886 the Board put a steam fog whistle on Gull Ledge in place of the bell, and a steam whistle wants a man to tend the boiler, so a second assistant was appointed. His name was Lyman Sprowl. He came out on the tender in May with a sea chest and a hymnbook.

He was thirty-five and he could preach. He had been a Methodist exhorter in Waldo County, not ordained, and the first Sunday on the ledge, with all three of them there because of the weather, Ansel asked him to read them a chapter and say something on it. He read them the prodigal son and talked about it for half an hour, and when he was done the two old men sat a while without getting up. They told each other afterward that they had got a minister out of the Board, and it was more than they had expected out of the Board.

That summer they took him in to the islands. Ragged Harbor had a meetinghouse and no minister, and Heron Island had no meetinghouse at all, and the Greens had nothing but a schoolhouse. Wherever the two keepers went they were known, and wherever they took Lyman the people asked him to speak, and after he spoke they asked him back. In July and August the three of them made the round of all the harbors where the keepers had friends, one keeper staying on the light, a Saturday night prayer meeting and a Sunday in each, and Lyman preaching. People cried. Children were named for him.

Lyman had his own thoughts. These two are old, he thought, and set in their ways, and they have had this light twenty years. He had a cousin who knew the new collector at Belfast, and the collector knew the congressman, and there was a new administration in Washington that was letting a good many old keepers go. If both of them went, he thought, there would be nobody to give the light to but the man who was already on it.

So one evening at the change of the watch he came to Ansel and said, *Mr. Pote, there is something I ought to say to you.*

Say it.

Lyman looked at the floor a while. *It's a hard thing,* he said. *I'd better not.* And he went down the stair, and went to Warren in the boiler house and did the same. The next evening he did it again to both of them. By the third evening the two old men were sick with it. Then Lyman came to Ansel in the watch room and said, *Mr. Pote, I don't like to say it to your face. Has Mr. Crockett got anything to do with you?*

What are you talking about? We're like two brothers. Twenty years. Whatever comes on this ledge for one of us is the other's. I never saw a wrong thing in him.

Is that so, said Lyman. *Well, I'm sorry, then. Because from the first week I came here he has been telling me to look out for you. He says you'll seem decent and quiet, and I'm not to trust you. He's said it more than once.*

Ansel heard that, and something in him went, the way a crock goes when you hit it with a stick. Lyman went down to the boiler house and said the same to Warren. Warren went the same way.

In twenty years neither of them had gone up the tower alone to light the lamp. The next evening Warren went up alone, ahead of time, and lit it, and came down, and Ansel passed him on the stair. On Sunday, Warren was to row Ansel in to meeting. He stood on the landing with his hands empty and thought, I'll not carry his coat. Then he thought, I have carried it two years, and it's my place to carry it, whatever he is. And he softened, and went up to the dwelling and said, *Give me the coat, Ansel.*

Ansel snapped his fingers in his face.

Get away from me. You're not fit to carry my coat.

That's all right, said Warren. *I'd already thought I wouldn't.*

Did you think I cared anything for this light?

Did you think I did? It's your light. Keep it.

They both wrote to the inspector that week. Ledge stations have two landings, one on the east end for a westerly blow and one on the west end for an easterly, and when the tender came in September Ansel went off by the east landing with his sea chest and Warren went off by the west, each in his own boat, and they did not look at each other. Lyman stood on the slip.

Don't do this, he said.
You stay, Lyman, they said.
So Lyman stayed.

V. The Islands

Ragged Harbor · the fall of 1886

The next Saturday Lyman came in to Ragged Harbor alone, and people asked him where the keepers were.

Don't ask me, Lyman said. *They had a falling out and both of them went off the ledge. I did everything I could to keep them. I couldn't.*

Some people said nothing. Others said, *We have known those two twenty years and never saw so much as a cross look between them. If they were scared off that ledge, it was this one that scared them.* They said it in their kitchens and not to his face, and the fall after, the Board made Lyman Sprowl keeper of Gull Ledge Light.

Ansel went east, Down East, to a light at the mouth of the Machias. Warren went west, all the way, and kept lights in Oregon. Neither one of them married. Neither one of them was any good afterward, the way they told it later. They could not keep a clean log. They lost their place in a chapter. Ansel would sit up in the watch room thinking, how could he say that of me, the day he saw that man come on the ledge. Three thousand miles away Warren sat up thinking, how could Ansel say that of me. Seventeen years went by like that.

VI. Tillamook

Tillamook Rock Light, Oregon · spring 1903

Ansel's sister's girl had married a man in the mills at Port Gamble on Puget Sound, where the East Machias people went, and when she was widowed she wrote for him. He got into the district out there. In March of 1903 he was ordered to Tillamook Rock.

Tillamook Rock is a lump of black basalt a mile off Tillamook Head, with the light and the keepers' dwelling built all in one on top of it, and

the sea goes over it in winter. There is no harbor and no beach. A man goes on and off it in a breeches buoy, swung up from the tender on the derrick line with his legs hanging, and his chest comes after him. Ansel was sixty-two. He came up out of the sea in the canvas breeches with his eyes shut, and the head keeper unbuckled him and took him in and showed him where he would sleep. There was one room for the assistants. There was a man sitting on the other bunk with his boots off.

Ansel sat down on the empty bunk and could not stop crying.

Warren had known him the moment he came through the door. He sat with his hands on his knees and his eyes full and thought, shall I say anything or shall I not. Then he thought, that is no way to think. He got up in his stocking feet and went and stood in front of Ansel.

Ansel. All those years I carried your coat, did you ever once know me to do a wrong thing? In what I did, or what I said, or what I thought?

No. Never.

Then why did you tell Lyman Sprowl to look out for me?

I never said any such thing. He told me you said it about me.

I never said it.

They looked at each other. Then they both understood it at once, the way you understand all at once that the fog is coming in. He did it on purpose. He did it to get the light. And each of them told the other what he had thought for seventeen years, and asked his pardon, and got it. The head keeper said afterward that he left them alone with the door shut and did not go in for an hour, and that when he did they were sitting side by side on the one bunk and had not lit the lamp.

They kept Tillamook together that summer. In August they gave their notice.

Let's go back, said Ansel, *and put him off our ledge.*

VII. The Slip

Gull Ledge · October 1903

They came across the continent on the cars, and from Rockland out on the mail boat, and from Ragged Harbor a man rowed

THEM TO THE LEDGE. LYMAN SAW THE BOAT COMING FROM THE gallery. He was fifty-two. He had kept Gull Ledge seventeen years and he had kept it well, and he still preached around the islands, and the islands still went to hear him, some of them.

He came down to the west slip to meet the boat. He knew them both before they were close. He waded out to his knees and took hold of the bow, and when they stood up he reached to take Ansel's bag and Warren's, the way a younger keeper does.

Ansel snapped his fingers in his face. Then Warren did.

Don't you touch it, said Ansel. *You are not fit to keep this light.*

That was all either of them said. It was not much. Lyman Sprowl had preached in every meetinghouse on the bay for seventeen years and been talked about by the whole coast and never once minded it, and he could not stand that one sentence. He let go of the boat. He walked up the slip and across the ledge and down the east landing, and he took the station dory and rowed out of the lee of the ledge into a southeast chop with the afternoon coming on, toward nowhere at all that anybody could make out. The assistant on duty hailed him from the gallery. He did not turn his head.

They found the dory on the Greens two days later, bottom up. They found him at low water on the west end of the ledge, in the weed, in his dress coat.

Ansel and Warren stayed the winter on the ledge until a new keeper came, and then they went in to Ragged Harbor and took a house together over the wharf, and they died in it, Ansel in 1907 and Warren the winter after.

VIII. The Library Box

Gull Ledge · September 1904

THE FOG WHISTLE HAD STARTED WHILE AMES WAS TELLING IT. It went every forty seconds, and the dishes in the rack answered it.

One sentence, said Charlie. *He did all that and they said one sentence to him.*

He did all that with sentences, said Ames.

He got up and went to the library box under the window, which had come out on the tender in July, and took out a book he had been reading in the afternoons. It was Franklin's life, written by himself. He had marked a page with a primary feather from a yellow-shafted woodpecker. In it Franklin set down the virtues he meant to practice, one to a page, and kept a little book in which he made a black spot against each one every day he failed it. Ames read three of them out under the lamp.

> *2. Silence. Speak not but what may benefit others or yourself; avoid trifling conversation.*
>
> *7. Sincerity. Use no hurtful deceit; think innocently and justly; and, if you speak, speak accordingly.*
>
> *8. Justice. Wrong none by doing injuries, or omitting the benefits that are your duty.*
>
> *— Benjamin Franklin, Autobiography*

The mouth, and what's back of it, and the hands, Ames said. *Keep them clean and you can stand to be looked at.* He put the feather back in at the page. *That's all there is to it. It's a short list.*

He took the watch at midnight. Ora relieved him at four. At sunrise the two of them went up and put out the lamp and hung the linen around the lens, and came down together, and at the window on the stair Ora stopped again. The tide was out. Charlie did not look; he had decided not to. Ora went on down.

Next Sunday Charlie was to row Ora in to Ragged Harbor for meeting. Ora came down to the boat in his good coat with nothing in his hands. Charlie was standing on the slip holding Ora's dinner pail, and he did not know himself why he had picked it up.

Background

The verse

> *Watching his speech, well restrained in mind, let a man never commit any wrong with his body! Let a man but keep these three roads of action clear, and he will achieve the way which is taught by the wise.*
>
> Dhammapada 281, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, coming down from Vulture's Peak with the elder Lakkhaṇa, smiles, and explains only before the Buddha: he has seen a peta with a man's body and a pig's head, with a tail growing out of its mouth and maggots oozing from the tail. The Buddha confirms it, having seen the same being long before and kept silent for the sake of those who would not believe. In the time of an earlier Buddha, he says, two elders, one a year senior to the other, lived together in a village monastery like brothers, the younger carrying the elder's bowl and robe. A gifted visiting preacher, whom they took round all their alms villages, wanted the monastery for himself; over three evenings he hinted at something too grave to say, then told each elder that the other had warned him against him. The elders were shattered like struck pots, quarreled over the bowl and robe, and left by the east and west doors, telling the preacher to stay. The villagers who were wise said the preacher must have driven them off. For a hundred years neither elder could recite or meditate; then both came to the same monastery in the far west and were given the same room, wept, asked each other whether either had ever done wrong in thought, word or deed, saw the slander, and were reconciled. They went back and drove the preacher out with a snap of the fingers, and he, who had meditated twenty thousand years, could not bear one rebuke, fled and died. Read the full commentary story.

Outer Penobscot Bay, Maine

Maine and Oregon light stations, 1866-1904

Under the Lighthouse Board (1852–1910) keepers were federal employees of the Treasury, appointed with a good deal of political influence until they were brought under civil service in 1896. Lamps burned kerosene from 1877; from 1884 keepers wore a navy-blue uniform with a K on the collar for the keeper and numbers for his assistants. From 1876 the Board sent isolated stations traveling libraries of about fifty books in a wooden case, exchanged every few months by the tenders. Keepers at stations in the path of the spring and fall bird migrations picked up the birds that struck the lantern at night, and some kept records of them for naturalists.

Tillamook Rock Light, lit in 1881 on a basalt rock off Tillamook Head, Oregon, was known as Terrible Tilly; keepers and supplies went on and off by derrick and breeches buoy, and four keepers lived in the dwelling built onto the tower. Maine people had gone to the Northwest since the 1850s, when the lumbermen of East Machias founded the mill town of Port Gamble on Puget Sound and recruited workers from home. Franklin's list of thirteen virtues is quoted from his *Autobiography* (ed. Frank Woodworth Pine, 1916). Gull Ledge, Ragged Harbor, and everyone in the story are invented.

After the story of the pig peta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 281). The original. Quotation from Benjamin Franklin's *Autobiography*, ed. Frank Woodworth Pine (1916). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.7

The Blue-Belly

We never understand these things until we experience them.
— Vivekananda, Raja Yoga (1896)

So I heard it told, on the far side of Mount Hamilton.

I. Empty Mr. Pottle

Chicago · winter 1903

Edwin Pottle had the whole Bhagavad Gita by heart in Sanskrit, seven hundred verses, and if you named a chapter and a number he would give you the verse, and then give it to you again in Telang's English and again in Arnold's, and tell you where each of them had gone wrong. He was forty-six years old and unmarried, an instructor in Sanskrit at the University on the Midway, and the author of *The Yoga Aphorisms of Patañjali, Rendered into English, with a Running Commentary*, which had been printed in Boston in 1899 and was going into a second edition. On Sunday afternoons he lectured in a hall on Michigan Avenue, and five hundred people paid a quarter to hear him. On weeknights he had eighteen parlor classes, from Prairie Avenue to Evanston, where women in shirtwaists and a few patient husbands sat in a ring of dining chairs while he took them through the eight limbs of the practice in order: restraint, observance, posture, breath, withdrawal, holding, meditation, absorption.

He explained the breath very well. He drew the nostrils on a slate. He had never done it.

The Swami had come to Chicago for the Parliament of Religions in 1893, as the companion of an older monk who afterward went home, and he had stayed. He lived in two rooms over a harness shop on Thirty-first

Street and cooked rice and lentils on a gas ring. He wore ochre cotton under a secondhand overcoat that came to his ankles. Nobody could say how old he was. He laughed easily and said very little, and the people who went to sit with him in the front room, on the floor, on a carpet with the pattern worn off, came out quieter than they went in. Pottle had found him in 1896. Every Wednesday since, after his last recitation of the day, he had ridden the Cottage Grove cable car north to drink a cup of tea with the Swami and tell him about the week: how many had come on Sunday, what had been asked, and what he had answered.

On a Wednesday in January the Swami opened the door and said, *Come in, empty Mr. Pottle.*

Pottle laughed. He supposed it was a turn of English the Swami had not got right, empty for hungry, perhaps. He came in and stamped the snow off.

Sit, empty Mr. Pottle. The Swami poured. *Sugar, empty Mr. Pottle?*

They talked about the Sunday lecture, which had been on the gunas. At nine Pottle stood and put on his coat, and the Swami saw him to the top of the stairs and said, *Good night, empty Mr. Pottle,* and as Pottle went down past the dark harness shop he heard the Swami say it once more, to the room, to nobody: *Empty Mr. Pottle has gone.*

The next Wednesday it was the same. And the next. In February he brought the proofs of the second edition, a hundred and forty pages in long galleys, and the Swami turned them over slowly on the carpet, one after another, nodding, and said, *Very fine, empty Mr. Pottle. Very fine.*

Pottle rode the cable car home that night with the galleys on his knees. He was not a vain man, or he did not think he was, and he made himself go over it honestly, the way he would go over a corrupt line of a manuscript. He had the Gita. He had the principal Upanishads and the commentaries on four of them. He had Patañjali in the Sanskrit and in his own English, nearly two hundred aphorisms, every word weighed. He taught eighteen classes. Five hundred people on Sunday. And the Swami called him empty.

Somewhere around Twenty-second Street he stopped arguing and counted. In seven years he had explained the first lesson of the practice

to perhaps two thousand people: sit for a time, and let the mind run on, and watch it. He had never sat for ten minutes together. He had always meant to. He had meant to begin after the first edition, and then after the Sunday lectures were established, and then after the second edition. He had read every word ever written about the water and had never once put his hand in it.

He got off the car at the next corner and walked the rest of the way home in the snow, and that night he wrote a letter to the head of his department and another to each of his eighteen hostesses, and he put two shirts and a razor and a tin of tooth powder in a valise. He did not pack a book.

II. The Day Coach

Westbound out of the Wells Street depot · March

He took the morning train west in the day coach, because a man going to learn something ought not to go by Pullman. The car was cold and smelled of oranges and wet wool. A man across the aisle in a brown derby nodded to him at Clinton, Iowa, and offered him a newspaper at Cedar Rapids, and somewhere on the flat white country past Council Bluffs Pottle understood that it was Mr. Hapgood.

Mr. Hapgood had been in the Thursday class at a house in Kenwood for three winters. He sold gloves at Field's. He was the slowest student Pottle had. He had never once got the eight limbs in the right order, and when he tried to say *pratyāhāra* it came out as something like a sneeze, and the ladies of the Thursday class were kind to him in the way that is not kind. He did not know Pottle at all. He had only ever seen him standing up, behind a little lectern, with a pointer.

They rode together for three days. Mr. Hapgood was going to his married sister in Oakland, for his chest. He talked about gloves, the weights of kid and the weights of chamois, and about the Platte River, which he had expected to be bigger. On the second night, somewhere in Wyoming, with the lamps turned down, he said that he went to a class on Thursdays, Hindu philosophy, very deep, mostly over his head.

Who is the teacher? Pottle said.

Fellow named Pottle. Wonderful talker. I couldn't keep the half of it. Mr. Hapgood looked out at the dark. *There was one thing I could manage. He said it the first night and I don't believe he ever said it again. Sit down and let your mind run, and just watch it. So that's what I do. Every night, on the edge of the bed, twenty minutes by the alarm clock. It's the only part I ever got.*

Pottle said nothing for a long time. Then he said that it sounded like the right part.

At Oakland they shook hands on the ferry, and Mr. Hapgood went off with his sister, a big woman in a feathered hat, and Pottle took the train down the bay to San Jose and in the morning climbed onto the observatory stage. The driver told him the road had three hundred and sixty-five turns, one for every day, and Pottle, who would once have wanted to count them, looked at the poppies instead. They passed under the white dome on the summit at noon, and on the other side the road went down into a country of oak and chaparral and gold grass where there was nothing to read for twenty miles.

III. Down the Line

Beyond Mount Hamilton · April 1903

Mrs. Harriet Lusk had been the Swami's first student in Chicago. When her husband died, and the money from the Board of Trade came to her, she bought a hundred and sixty acres in the hills past the observatory, and in the spring of 1900 eleven of the Swami's people came out with her to live on it. They lived in tents and in one board cabin. They had dug their own well and cut their own wood, and twice a day, at dawn and at dusk, they sat. The Swami came out for one summer to start them and then went back to his rooms over the harness shop, and they kept on without him. They did not write many letters. Pottle had thought of them, when he thought of them at all, as the ones who had left the lectures.

He walked in from the stage road with his valise. Mrs. Lusk was sitting in the shade of a live oak shelling peas into a dishpan. She was sixty-eight. She looked up and knew him at once.

Mrs. Lusk, he said. *I've come to be taught.*

Mr. Pottle. She put down the pod in her hand. *We read your Patañjali aloud by the lamp, all last winter. It is we who ought to be taught by you.*

Please don't, he said. *Please. Teach me.*

She looked at him a while longer. She looked at his collar and his good shoes and the valise. *Go and ask Captain Ames,* she said, and went back to the peas.

Captain Ames had been master of a lake steamer between Chicago and Mackinac for thirty years. He was splitting oak behind the cabin. He heard Pottle out, leaning on the maul, and said there were people on the place who knew a good deal more about it than an old lake captain did, and sent him to Miss Pruitt. Miss Pruitt, who had taught the sixth grade in Oak Park, was carrying water from the spring in two buckets on a yoke, and she would not put them down to talk, so he walked beside her, asking, and at the cabin door she sent him to Mr. Brandt. Mr. Brandt was a German baker from Halsted Street and was kneading bread on a board in the shade, and he sent him to the Lindqvist sisters, who were mending fence, and they sent him to young Mr. Coyle, who was twenty-two and had been a newsboy and was lying on his back under the wagon greasing an axle.

Each of them was courteous. Each of them said, in one way or another, that Mr. Pottle had written the book. Each of them sent him a little further down. It took the whole afternoon. By the time the sun was low over the ridge he had been sent down the entire place, from the oldest of them to the youngest grown one, and the sending had done something to him that the Swami's word had only begun. He had stopped explaining who he was.

Mrs. Dolan was the last of the grown ones. She had been a dressmaker on the West Side and had come out a widow with her little girl. She was sitting on an upturned crate turning the collar of a shirt. She listened to

him, and her mouth moved a little at one corner, and she pointed with her scissors to the cabin step.

Teresa Dolan was seven. Everyone on the place called her Tessie. She was sitting on the step in the last of the sun, hemming a dish towel cut from a flour sack, with the miller's red letters still faint in the cloth. As Pottle came up she bit off her thread and wet the end of a new one and threaded her needle without looking at it, the way her mother had taught her, by feel, with her eyes on him.

He took off his hat. He held it in front of him in both hands.

Miss Dolan, he said. *Will you teach me?*

Tessie considered him. *You're the man that wrote the book,* she said. *Mama reads it to me when I can't get to sleep.*

Mrs. Dolan, on her crate, bent closer over the collar.

Please, Pottle said. *Teach me.*

If you'll do what I say.

Anything you say. If you told me to walk into a fire, I would walk into it.

She thought about this seriously, and stuck the needle into the towel for safekeeping, and pointed down the slope past the corral.

Walk into the tank, she said.

IV. The Tank

The same evening

The stock pond lay below the corral in a fold of the hill, brown water with a skin of gold on it from the low sun, the mud of the bank stamped all over with the hooves of a neighbor's cattle. Pottle had on a grey worsted suit made for him by a tailor on State Street, a waistcoat, a celluloid collar, and his father's gold watch on a chain across the front. He did not take anything off. He did not stop at the edge to think about it, which was the first thing in his life, he said afterward, that he had not stopped to think about. He walked down through the mud and into the water and kept walking until it was over his belt, and over his watch, and up to his chest, and so cold that it took his breath out of him in one piece.

Up on the slope everyone had stopped what they were doing. Captain Ames stood with the maul. Mr. Brandt had flour to his elbows. Mrs. Lusk had come out from under the oak with the dishpan still on her hip.

Come out now, Tessie called.

He came out. The water ran out of his cuffs and his trouser legs and his pockets, and his good shoes were two lumps of mud. He climbed the slope and stood in front of the cabin step, dripping on the boards, and waited.

Tessie looked him up and down to see that he had done it properly. Then she told him.

This morning there was a blue-belly on the woodpile, and I chased him, and he went down the squirrel holes on the knoll. There's six holes up there and they all go to the same place underneath. If you run around all the holes you never get him. He just comes up the one you're not at. She held up her hand with the fingers spread, and folded them down one at a time. *So you put a rock on one, and a rock on one, and a rock on one, and a rock on one, and a rock on one. And you sit by the one he went in. And you don't look at the others.*

The one finger stood up by itself.

And then he comes out where you are.

Pottle stood with the pond water running into his shoes. He knew the aphorism; he had rendered it himself, with a page of commentary, the withdrawal of the senses from their objects, the mind gathered toward. He had given it on a slate to two thousand people. It had never once been anything but words, and now a child had held up five fingers and folded them down, and it was as if someone had lit a lamp in a room he had been living in for twenty years without knowing it had walls.

That's enough, he said. *Thank you. That's enough.*

He went up the knoll in his wet clothes before the light was gone.

V. Six Holes

The knoll · April and May

THE KNOLL WAS ROUND AND BARE ON TOP, WITH WILD OATS ON its shoulders and a single blue oak, and the ground squirrels had worked

IT OVER FOR LONGER THAN ANYONE HAD LIVED THERE. POTTLE found six holes close together where the earth was loose and pale. He carried a stone to each of five and set it over the mouth. He sat down by the sixth with his legs crossed in the way he had drawn on so many slates, and his knees told him at once what they thought of it.

The first thing that happened was the Gita. It started up in his head by itself, the first chapter, the two armies drawn up on the field, and ran on verse after verse without being asked. Then it was the Sunday lecture he had not given, on the five sheaths, beautifully organized. Then it was the second edition, a misprint on page forty, a letter he ought to write to the printer. Then it was Mr. Hapgood. Then it was his father, and the watch, which had stopped at seven minutes past six. Then it was a sentence about the mind as a drunken monkey, which he had always delivered well, and which he now watched going by like a man watching a parade he had once been in. He did not chase any of it. He sat by the one hole and let it run, the way the first lesson said, and watched it, and when he caught himself following a thing down some other hole he came back.

The suit dried on him stiff, with a tidemark at the chest. When the dark came, Mrs. Dolan brought up a blanket and a plate of beans and went away without speaking.

He came down to sleep and to eat and to carry water, because everyone carried water, and the rest of the time he sat on the knoll. The others sat at dawn and dusk in a ring under the oak by the cabin, and after the first week he could see them from up there, small and still, and once he understood that they could see him. The squirrels got used to him. A red-tailed hawk worked the slope every afternoon at the same hour, and he heard it before he saw it, and then one afternoon he did not look up at it at all. His knees stopped talking. The Gita came less often and left sooner. Tessie came up some days with her sewing and sat on one of the five stones, the one nearest the oak, and hemmed, and did not say anything either, and threaded her needle by feel.

On an evening in the middle of May he looked up and the Swami was standing in the wild oats below the oak.

He was in the ochre cotton and the long secondhand overcoat, buttoned, as if it were still January on Thirty-first Street. The sun was going down behind Pottle's back, but the light on the Swami came from in front of him, from somewhere behind the Swami himself, so that the oat heads all around him were lit at their edges and the coat was gold at every seam. He was two thousand miles from his gas ring and his carpet, and he was there, and he smiled at Pottle the way he had smiled over the galleys, and said the words from the Swami Vivekananda's book, which Pottle had quoted to five hundred people on a Sunday without once hearing them:

> *Practice is absolutely necessary. You may sit down and listen to me by the hour every day, but, if you do not practise, you will not get one step further. It all depends on practice. We never understand these things until we experience them.*
>
> *— Vivekananda, Raja Yoga (1896)*

Then there was only the oak and the oats, and the light was the ordinary light going down.

Mrs. Lusk said afterward that she had seen something on the knoll that evening, from the ring under the oak, and taken it for the sun on a stone. Captain Ames said he had seen nothing at all and did not need to. Tessie said that of course it was the Swami, who else would it be, and that he had been wearing his coat.

Pottle sat on. The light went off the hill. Below him the sixth hole was a small round dark, no different from the dark coming up out of the valley, and he watched it, and there was nothing between him and the watching anymore, no lectern, no slate, no page of commentary, nothing but the hole and the evening and the one doing the watching, and then not even that.

In the last warmth a blue-belly came up out of the sixth hole and climbed onto the nearest stone. It lifted itself on its front legs, twice, three times, the way they do, and the blue of its belly showed in the last

light like a scrap of the sky that had got down there. Pottle did not reach for it. It stayed on the stone until the stone went cold.

• • •

He stayed on the place through the summer and the fall. Tessie sewed the button back on his waistcoat, the one the pond had taken, with black thread because there was no grey. In November he went back to Chicago on the day coach, and on the first Wednesday he rode the Cottage Grove car up to Thirty-first Street and climbed the stairs over the harness shop, and the Swami opened the door.

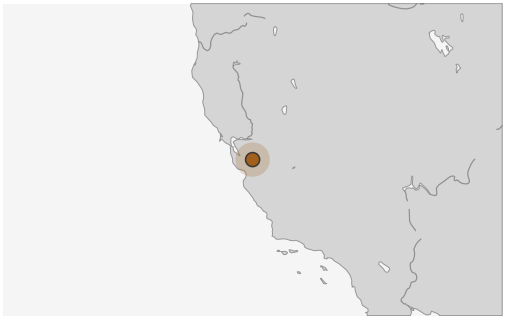
Come in, Mr. Pottle, he said. *Sit.*

Background

The verse

> *Through zeal knowledge is gotten, through lack of zeal knowledge is lost; let a man who knows this double path of gain and loss thus place himself that knowledge may grow.*
>
> Dhammapada 282, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Poṭhila knows all three baskets of the teaching by heart and recites them to five hundred monks, but has never practiced. The Buddha begins to greet him every day as "Empty Poṭhila": come, Empty Poṭhila; sit, Empty Poṭhila; Empty Poṭhila has gone. Stung, Poṭhila leaves at dawn in the company of the least of his students, who do not notice who he is, and travels a hundred and twenty leagues to a forest hermitage of thirty monks who have all reached the goal. He asks the eldest to be his refuge, and is sent to the next, and the next, down to a seven-year-old novice sitting at his sewing. The boy agrees to teach him if he will obey, and tells him to walk into a pond in his costly robes; he does. Then the boy tells him how to catch a lizard that has gone into an anthill with six holes: stop five, and watch the one it went in by. So with the six doors of the senses. As Poṭhila sits, the Buddha, far away, sends a radiant image of himself to speak the verse. Read the full commentary story.



Chicago and the hills past Mount Hamilton, California

Chicago and the hills past Mount Hamilton, 1893–1903

The World's Parliament of Religions met in Chicago from September 11 to 27, 1893, alongside the Columbian Exposition, in the building that is now the Art Institute. Its best-remembered speaker was the young Bengali monk Vivekananda, who stayed on in America to lecture. His lectures in New York in the winter of 1895–96 became *Raja Yoga*, published in July 1896: an account of the eight limbs of practice with a free translation of the Yoga Sutras of Patañjali. Its chapter on pratyahara, the "gathering towards" or withdrawal of the senses, tells the beginner to sit and let the mind run on, and watch it. The Swami, Edwin Pottle and the Chicago circle are fictional.

In 1900 Vivekananda's brother disciple Turiyananda took a dozen or so American students to a gift of 160 acres in the San Antonio Valley, some eighteen miles southeast of Lick Observatory on Mount Hamilton. They lived in tents, hauled their own water and meditated. The place, the Shanti Ashrama, is still a retreat. Mrs. Lusk's ranch is loosely modeled on it. The hills there are full of California ground squirrels, whose colonies dig burrow systems with many entrances, which other animals use as refuges, and of western fence lizards, which every California child knows as bluebellies.

After the story of the elder Poṭhila from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 282). The original. Scripture from Swami Vivekananda's *Raja Yoga* (Longmans, Green, 1896). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.8

Sweet Root

Our throats are tired, our mouths are sore;
The sea refilleth evermore.
— Jātaka 146

Evaṃ me sutaṃ, on Pakse Street.

I. The Committee

Iberia Parish, Louisiana · 1986

There were five of them, and in the Lao families between Lafayette and New Iberia they were called the Committee, though they had never been elected to anything. They were old men. They had been somebodies on the other side of the Mekong. Khamsing had bought and sold rice in Savannakhet and owned two trucks. Bounlieng had been a district officer under the King and had spent four years after 1975 in a seminar camp in Houaphan, which was what the new government called the places where it sent men like him, and had come out with no teeth on one side. Phoumy had been a captain. Thongdy had taught school. Sengdao had owned a pharmacy in Pakse and still could not walk past one in Lafayette without going in to read the labels.

They had swum the river or been rowed across it at night, and waited in the camp at Nong Khai for one year or three, and been sent by the Catholic diocese to a place none of them had heard of, where the land was as flat as the land around Vientiane and the water was the color of tea and the summers were the same, and the first thing every one of them said, getting off the bus in New Iberia in the wet heat, was that it was like home. Then they went to work. They peeled crawfish and shucked oysters. Khamsing sorted potatoes into cans. Phoumy picked peppers on

Avery Island for the hot sauce, and came home with his hands burning. Two of them got on in the oil yards in the boom, welding and cleaning pipe, and made more money than they had ever seen, and in 1986 the price of oil fell to thirteen dollars a barrel and Louisiana had the worst unemployment in the country and the yards let them go, and it did not matter much by then, because they were old and their sons were working.

They had always done things together. On the other side of the river they had built a school, and here they did what there was to do. They found sponsors for cousins. They drove people to the hospital and the immigration office and translated. They collected money, twenty dollars and fifty dollars at a time, from families who had very little, and in the spring of 1986 they used it to buy eleven acres of cut-over cane land at the end of a shell road north of town, cheap, because nobody else wanted it, and they laid out three streets and named them for Lao towns, Pakse and Vientiane and Luang Prabang, and the families began to build. People called it Ban Mai, the new village.

At the end of Pakse Street, against the cane, they bought a ranch house for a temple and wrote to a temple in Thailand for a monk.

The monk they got was Achan Khamphan, who was sixty and very thin and had spent nine years in the forest temples of the northeast before the war came over the river and he went into the camps to teach. He arrived in July of 1986 with a bowl, three robes, a razor and a water filter, and a paperback dictionary that he gave to the first child who asked him a question in English. He did not say much. When he did say something, people repeated it to each other for a week.

Mae Wan cooked for all of it.

She was Khamsing's wife, a small round woman with her hair pulled back tight and a laugh you could hear on the next street, and her name meant sweet, and everybody said it fit. She had a garden that ran the whole depth of the lot behind her house on Pakse Street: lemongrass and galangal and three kinds of chili, holy basil, long beans on a trellis made from oilfield pipe, eggplants the size of marbles, and along the back fence a row of the tall coarse grass that the Cajun lady next door called vetiver and dug up every fall to dry the roots and fold in with her sheets,

and that Mae Wan called faek and used for the same thing. Her shelves were jars. Jeow bong, black-red and sweet and hot, that she made with dried buffalo skin when she could get it and pork skin when she couldn't. Jeow made with roasted tomatoes, with roasted eggplant, with fish. And in the shed, in a crock with a plate on it and a brick on the plate, padaek, the fermented fish sauce without which nothing tasted like anything, that she made from buffalo fish she bought from a Cajun fisherman at Henderson on the levee, because nobody in Louisiana sold the right fish.

Every meeting the Committee ever held, they held on her porch. Every meeting, she fed them.

II. The Robes

The temple at the end of Pakse Street · July 1987

THE NEW HALL WAS FINISHED IN THE SUMMER OF 1987, CINDER block with a steep tin roof that the men of the village had cut and bent by hand to sweep up at the corners the way the roofs did at home, and it was painted gold at the eaves. On the first day of the rains retreat the whole village came, the women in their silk skirts with the sticky rice in baskets, the men in their good shirts with a silk sash across them, and Achan Khamphan gave the sermon.

He talked about old age. He did not talk long. He said that a man is born and works and marries and has children and builds a house and builds a temple, and all of it is good, and then he is old, and the house and the children and the temple go on without him, as they should. He said there are two kinds of old men. One kind holds on harder every year to what is leaving him. The other kind puts it down while he can still choose to. He said that was all.

The five of them talked about it on Mae Wan's porch that night. Khamsing said it first.

We are old men. What are we doing? We bought the land. The temple is up. Our sons have jobs. What are we waiting for, to die in a recliner in front of the Thai videos?

Mae Wan, who was bringing out the rice, put the basket down and looked at her husband for a long time. Then she laughed her big laugh and said: *Go on. I always knew I would have to give you to the temple sooner or later. Better now, while you can still sweep.*

They divided what they had among their children that summer. Khamsing gave his car to his oldest son and the house to Mae Wan. Sengdao, who had saved the most, gave the most. In October, at the end of the rains, two monks drove over from the temple in Texas and two from the one in Tennessee, because it took that many to ordain a monk properly, and in the new hall in front of the whole village the five old men had their heads and eyebrows shaved and put on the saffron robes, and became monks.

Then the trouble began, which was that they could not learn anything.

A monk is supposed to know the chanting by heart. The morning chant and the evening chant, the blessings, the verses for the dead, and on the full moon and the new moon the long recitation of the rules, two hundred and twenty-seven of them, which takes most of an hour. The young monks who came to the temple from Thailand had learned it all as boys. The five of them sat up at night in the hall with the books and their reading glasses and the Pali swam on the page, and in the morning it was gone. Bounlieng had once been able to recite whole provincial budgets from memory. Now he could not hold four lines. Thongdy, who had taught school for thirty years, wept with shame over it once and then never again.

Achan Khamphan did not scold them. He told them to learn what they could and to sweep the hall.

The temple was small and there was no room for them in the monks' house, so they built themselves a hut at the edge of the temple land, against the cane, out of plywood and a sheet of tin and a window from the dump, with a mosquito net over five mats, and lived there together the way they had always done everything. In the evenings they could hear the young monks chanting in the hall, and they sat in the door of the hut and listened, and moved their lips.

III. The Porch

Pakse Street · 1987–1988

EVERY MORNING AT SIX THE MONKS WALKED OUT OF THE temple gate barefoot in a line, oldest in ordination first, with their bowls in front of them under their robes, down Pakse Street and up Vientiane and back along Luang Prabang, and the women knelt at the edge of their yards on mats with the rice baskets and put a ball of sticky rice in each bowl as it passed, and something wrapped in a banana leaf or a twist of plastic, and bowed, and the monks did not thank them, because it was the giver who was being done a favor.

The five old men walked at the end of the line, because they were the youngest monks, and the oldest. And the thing everybody noticed, though nobody said it out loud for a long time, was that they walked slower and slower as they came down Pakse Street, and slower still in front of their own houses. Phoumy's daughter-in-law put fried fish in his bowl that she put in nobody else's. Thongdy's wife cried every morning when he passed and he looked at the ground. And at Mae Wan's gate the line simply came apart, and the old men stopped.

Monks eat once a day, in the morning, and must finish before noon, and they may eat where they are invited. Mae Wan invited them. So the young monks went on with Achan Khamphan to eat in the hall, and the five old men went up onto Mae Wan's porch, where she had laid a clean cloth on the boards and set out every jar on her shelf, and sat down in a row and ate there, out of their bowls, with their fingers, the sticky rice rolled into a ball and pressed into the jeow bong, the way they had eaten on that porch every day of their lives.

She did not sit with them. She could not. A monk may not touch a woman or take a thing from her hand, so she set each dish on the cloth and pushed it toward them, and knelt a little way off with her hands together, and watched them eat. Khamsing was her husband for forty-one years and now he was a monk and she was a woman kneeling on her own porch, and she did not seem to mind it. She made fun of them. She told Bounlieng he chewed like a goat. She told Sengdao he had been too

stingy with sugar his whole life and was going to get it all now, and gave him the sweet jeow. She asked them every morning if they had learned the chanting yet, and they said no, and she laughed, and they laughed, and ate.

The young monks did not like it. One of them, Phra Sone, who was twenty-four and very correct and had come from a great temple in Ubon, said so to Achan Khamphan: that the old men did not keep to the line, that they went every day to the same house, that they ate on a woman's porch and laughed with her, that people were talking. Achan Khamphan listened and nodded and did nothing.

In the spring the village rented two vans and drove down to Cypremort Point on Vermilion Bay for the day, where there was a beach of trucked-in sand and you could look at salt water. The monks came. The five old men sat in a row on a picnic table in their robes, under a tin shelter, and watched the brown water come in and go out. A gang of crows was working the edge of it, walking along the wet sand with their shoulders up, picking at what the water left. Mae Wan sat on a cooler in the shade behind them with a plate of food.

It looks like the river at home in the flood, she said. *Big and brown. Except it never goes down.*

The crows came round the picnic table for scraps and she threw them sticky rice, and they fought over it, and she laughed until she had to wipe her eyes.

IV. The Hut

October 1988

She had the sweet sickness. The Lao called it that, and the doctors in New Iberia called it diabetes, and she had had it for years and paid it no attention, because she felt fine and because she made a great deal of jeow bong. In September of 1988 her feet began to swell. She went to the hospital in New Iberia and came home and went back again. Her kidneys were going. In the second week of October, during

THE CANE HARVEST, SHE LAY DOWN FOR A REST IN THE AFTERnoon in the room at the back of the house and did not get up.

The village did what you do. The monks went to the funeral home in Lafayette and sat in a row along the wall of the chapel while the people of the village came through, and a white cotton thread ran from her coffin to the monks' hands, and the young monks chanted the verses for the dead, and the five old men moved their lips. Khamsing did not touch her. He could not. He sat with the thread in his fingers and looked at the coffin and did not look away from it.

They came home after dark. They walked back to the temple from the van and went into their hut, and the door shut, and for a few minutes it was quiet.

Then the whole village heard it.

It came out of the hut at the edge of the cane like nothing anybody in Ban Mai had heard since the camps, five old men weeping out loud, howling, the way children do, the way nobody does after the age of six. Phra Sone was the first one there. He ran across the temple yard in his bare feet with his robe hitched up and two of the others behind him, and he pulled open the door of the hut, and the five old monks were standing in the middle of it holding on to each other, their arms around each other's necks, their shaved heads together, rocking, with the tears running down into their robes.

Brothers. Brothers. What is it? What happened?

It was Sengdao who answered, because he could still talk.

Mae Wan is dead. Mae Wan is dead. Our friend's wife. She fed us every day of our lives. Where are we going to find another one like her? Where? Who is going to feed us now?

And they all began again.

Phra Sone stood in the door and did not know what to do. Behind him the others came running, the rest of the monks and then half of Pakse Street in their house slippers, children, Mae Wan's own sons, people with flashlights. Monks do not weep for women. Monks of sixty-eight and seventy do not stand in a hut with their arms around each other's necks and cry for a woman's cooking. Somebody laughed and was hushed. Some-

body else was crying too, out in the dark. Phra Sone said, *Brothers, please, people can hear you,* and they did not stop.

V. The Crows

The hall · the same night

THE YOUNG MONKS WENT BACK TO THE HALL. THEY SAT IN THE lamplight under the gold Buddha and talked about it in low voices, all of them at once: how it looked, how it would look, what the families would say, what the temple in Texas would say if it heard. A monk weeping for his wife like a husband. The other four weeping for their dinners.

Achan Khamphan came in from his room and sat down.

What are you all talking about?

They told him. He listened to all of it. Then he was quiet a while, and the young monks waited, and outside the hut had gone quieter too, and you could hear the old men through the wall of cane, not howling now, only talking to each other in their hoarse voices, and once Bounlieng blowing his nose.

This is not the first time they have done this, Achan Khamphan said. *They did the same thing before. Long ago, when they were crows.*

And he told them the story the way the old monks used to tell it in the forest temples, in the evenings, with the lamps lit.

Once there was a crow and his wife, he said, and a whole company of crows who were their friends, and they lived by the sea. One day some people came down to the shore to make an offering to the serpents who live under the water. They set out rice and milk and fish and meat and strong drink, and went away. The crows came down and ate all of it, and drank all the drink, and got very drunk, the whole company, and they decided to go swimming. They hopped into the surf, laughing, and a big wave came and took the crow's wife out to sea, and a fish ate her.

Her husband began to wail. The whole company came running to see what was wrong, and when he told them, they all began to wail with him. Then one of them said, *We are crows. We are strong. We will empty the sea and get her back.* So all of them, every crow, began to bail out the ocean,

taking up the water in their beaks a mouthful at a time and flying up the beach to spit it out on the sand, and flying back, and taking another mouthful. They worked all day. Their beaks were raw from the salt and their eyes were red and their throats were burning, and every time they emptied out one place the water ran back in. At last they stopped and looked at each other, and said:

> *Our throats are tired, our mouths are sore;*
> *The sea refilleth evermore.*
> *— Jātaka 146*

And then, Achan Khamphan said, instead of going home, they sat down on the shore and began to tell each other how beautiful she had been. Her eyes. Her beak. Her feathers. Her sweet voice. It was because she was so beautiful, they said, that the sea had wanted her and taken her. They were still sitting there telling each other that when the spirit who kept that shore got tired of the noise, and rose up out of the water with a terrible face, and frightened them so badly that they flew away and did not stop until they were home.

Phra Sone said, *And the spirit of the shore?*

Achan Khamphan smiled a little, which he did not often do. *Somebody has to make a face at them,* he said, *or they would still be there.*

One of the youngest monks laughed and then looked frightened that he had. Achan Khamphan stood up and put his robe straight on his shoulder and went out across the yard to the hut.

VI. The Cane

The edge of the cane · October

THE NEXT MORNING THEY WERE BURNING THE CANE.

The farmer who owned the land behind the temple had cut the field the week before with the big harvesters, and the stalks lay in long rows on the ground the way the machines left them, and before daylight his men went down the rows with drip torches and set the leaves on fire, as

they did every fall all over the parish, to burn off the trash. By the time the monks came back from the almsround the whole field was a low wall of flame moving slowly away from the temple with the wind, and the smoke stood up off it brown and white, and the ash came down all over Ban Mai in black flakes as light as paper, on the cars and the laundry and the gold roof of the hall, and on the shaved heads of the old monks sitting in the door of their hut.

They had not gone on the almsround. They had not eaten. Achan Khamphan had sat with them in the hut until very late, and nobody knew what he had said to them, and in the morning he came back and sat down on the ground in front of the door, and the young monks came and stood behind him, and some of the village came too, because they had heard the night before and wanted to see.

Across the road, in the Cajun farmer's pasture, they were weaning the calves. The cows were in one pen and the calves in the next one over, with a fence between, and the calves had been bawling for their mothers since before light, a raw, steady, helpless sound, and the cows bawled back, and the calves pushed their heads through the wire toward them, and would not stop, and would not stop.

Achan Khamphan pointed to the cane fire.

When the farmer cuts, he said, *he does not cut one stalk. He cuts the whole field. Then he burns what is left on the ground, all of it. If he cut one stalk, the field would stand there laughing at him. You cut one thing. You cut the house. You cut the car and the bank account and the business, you gave it all to your sons, you cut your hair and your eyebrows. Good. That was one stalk. The field is still standing. The field is all the wanting. Wanting the house, wanting the wife, wanting the sons, wanting the porch, wanting the jeow bong. That is where the fear comes from. That is where the crying comes from.*

He nodded across the road at the weaning pens.

Listen to them. As long as there is any of that left in a man, even a little, even this much, he is tied like that calf to the milk.

Then he said the verses he had brought them, slowly, in Lao, the way the old teachers had, and afterward one of the boys in the village who was at the university in Lafayette found them for Phra Sone in an old

English book in the library, and copied them out, and the young monk kept the paper in his bag for years.

> *Whom she doth overcome,—the shameful jade,*
> *Craving, the poisoner of all mankind,—*
> *Grow for him griefs as rank as jungle-grass.*
>
> *This word to you, as many as are here*
> *Together come: May all success be yours!*
> *Dig up the root of craving, as ye were*
> *Bent on the quest of sweet usira root.*
>
> *— Theragāthā 400, 402*

Usira is the old name for the root Mae Wan grew along her back fence, the one the Cajun lady next door dug up every fall and dried and folded in with her sheets. Faek. Vetiver. Anybody who has dug it knows that you cannot pull it. You have to dig, and keep digging, because the roots go straight down as far as a man is tall, and the sweetness is all down there in the root, in the dark, and none of it in the grass.

Khamsing was the first to stand up. He went into the hut and came out with his bowl, and the others came out after him with theirs, and they put their robes straight, and Achan Khamphan nodded at them, and that was all.

• • •

People said afterward that the five old men were different after that, though they never did learn the chanting, not even the short ones. Mae Wan's sons gave her jars to the temple kitchen, and the women cooked with them until they were gone. The crock in the shed they gave to Bounlieng's daughter-in-law, who had always wanted to know how Mae Wan did it, and opened it, and found it had gone exactly right.

The next morning, and every morning after that, the monks walked out of the temple gate at six in a line with their bowls, down Pakse Street. Mae Wan's daughter-in-law knelt at the edge of the yard where Mae Wan had knelt, on the same mat, with the rice basket, and put a ball of sticky

rice in each bowl as it passed, and in Khamsing's too. He did not slow down. The line did not come apart. Behind the house the row of faek stood along the back fence, tall and coarse and green, with the ash from the cane fires settling on it, and the crows walking up and down the burned field behind the temple, picking at what the fire had left.

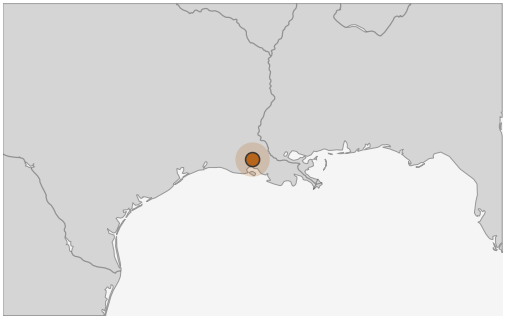
Background

The verses

> *Cut down the whole forest (of lust), not a tree only! Danger comes out of the forest (of lust). When you have cut down both the forest (of lust) and its undergrowth, then, Bhikshus, you will be rid of the forest and free!*
>
> Dhammapada 283, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *So long as the love of man towards women, even the smallest, is not destroyed, so long is his mind in bondage, as the calf that drinks milk is to its mother.*
>
> Dhammapada 284, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a company of rich old householders of Sāvatthī, friends who did good works together, hear the Buddha and decide that they are too old to stay in the world. They become monks, but they are too old to learn the teachings by heart, so they build a hut of leaves at the edge of the monastery and live there together, and on their almsround they eat at their own wives' and sons' houses, above all at the house of one monk's former wife, Madhurapācikā, the "sweet cook," who feeds them all from her store of sauces and curries. When she dies, the old monks fall on one another's necks and weep. The other monks come running, and the Buddha tells them that the old men did the same in a former life, as crows who tried to bail out the sea to get back a drowned friend. That past-life story is the Kāka Jātaka (Jātaka 146), quoted here in Robert Chalmers's translation (1895). The closing verses are from the Theragāthā, the verses of the early monks, in C. A. F. Rhys Davids's *Psalms of the Brethren* (1913). Read the full commentary story.



Iberia Parish, Louisiana

Iberia Parish, 1986–1988

After 1975, tens of thousands of refugees from Laos crossed the Mekong into camps in Thailand, many of them men of the old Royal Lao Government and army, and thousands of officials were sent to the new government's re-education camps, which it called seminars, many of them in Houaphan province. Many who resettled in the United States came to south Louisiana through Catholic diocese sponsorship, and found work peeling shrimp and crawfish, shucking oysters, picking peppers for the Tabasco factory, and in the oil boom. Ban Mai is fictional, but it is modeled on Lane Xang Village between Lafayette and New Iberia, where, as historian Davorn Sisavath describes, Lao families bought land in 1986, laid out streets named for Lao cities, and built a temple in 1987. The oil price collapse of 1986, part of the 1980s oil glut, gave Louisiana the highest unemployment rate in the nation that year.

Elderly Lao men often ordain as monks late in life, and in Lao and Thai temples the monks walk an almsround at dawn while laypeople kneel to place sticky rice in their bowls. In the fall harvest, south Louisiana cane growers burn the cut fields to clear the leafy trash, and the ash drifts over the towns. Vetiver, the Pali *usīra*, has long been grown in Louisiana, and New Orleans families folded its dried roots in with their stored linens.

After the story of a company of old elders from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 283 and 284). The original. Scripture from *The Jātaka*, vol. 1, tr. Robert Chalmers (1895), and *Psalms of the Early Buddhists II: Psalms of the Brethren*, tr. C. A. F. Rhys Davids (1913). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.9

Gold Leaf

I loved the garish day, and, spite of fears,
Pride ruled my will.
— "Lead, Kindly Light"

The way I heard it, on Kenilworth Avenue.

I. Five Hundred Windows

U Street, Washington · 1919–1968

Augustus Pettaway lettered his first window in 1919, for a barber on U Street who paid him four dollars and a free shave every Saturday for a year. He lettered his last one in the spring of 1968. In between, by the count in the black ledger he kept in a cigar box under the counter of his shop on Ninth Street, he did five hundred and eleven windows in gold leaf between Seventh Street and Fourteenth, and some on Georgia Avenue, and a few out in Northeast. Barbershops and beauty parlors. Funeral homes. Pharmacies, insurance companies, a bank, two theaters, a dozen lawyers, a great many churches. When people said Black Broadway, the gold on the glass up and down U Street was a good part of what they meant, and most of it was his.

It was done on the inside of the glass, backward. That was the first thing his grandson Calvin learned, at five, standing on an apple crate in a doorway with a book of leaf in his hand. You laid out the letters in reverse on a paper pattern and taped it to the street side, and then you went inside and worked the letters from behind, so that from the sidewalk they read true. You mixed the size, a pinch of gelatin dissolved in hot water from a thermos, and flowed it on the glass with a soft brush. Then you took a leaf of twenty-three karat gold out of the book. You did not touch

it. Nothing touched it except the gilder's tip, a wide flat brush of squirrel hair, which you drew once across your own cheek to give it a little of your skin's oil, and then held near the leaf until the leaf leapt up to it and hung there trembling. Then you brought it to the wet glass, and the instant it came near, the water pulled the gold off the brush and laid it flat, and it took.

Calvin's job, until he was eight, was to hold the book and not breathe. A leaf of gold is so thin a breath will crumple it. His grandfather said it was a thousand times thinner than a page of the Bible. When Calvin was nine his grandfather let him lay a leaf himself, the dot over the *i* in *Dentist*, and when he was twelve he did a whole word, and when he was fourteen he could burnish leaf with a wad of cotton until you could see your face in it, and back up the letters with paint, and wipe away the gold that wasn't letters, and lay a black shadow line along each stroke so it stood up off the glass like something you could pick up and carry away. He had the hands for it. His father had the hands for it. His grandfather said the Pettaways had been working gold since Africa and maybe before Africa, and nobody could prove different.

On the night of April fourth, 1968, word came up Fourteenth Street that Dr. King had been shot in Memphis, and by morning U Street was burning.

It went on four days. When it was over and the troops were standing on the corners, Augustus Pettaway walked up and down Fourteenth and Seventh and U with Calvin, who was nineteen, and looked at his windows. Most of them were not there. Where they were, the fire had been at them from inside and the gold had curled up off the glass and gone black, like the edges of a paper you hold over a match. He stood a long time in front of a pharmacy he had lettered in 1931, where there was nothing left in the frame but three black curls of leaf stuck to a shard. He did not say anything. He went home to Ninth Street and put the ledger back in the cigar box and closed the shop, and in August he died.

In 1969 Calvin was drafted. In Vietnam, at a firebase in the hills west of Huế, a boy from Detroit showed him what you could buy from the children at the wire for two dollars, in a little glass vial, white as talcum and

stronger than anything that had ever been on Fourteenth Street. By the time they put him on the plane home in 1971 he had it in him like a second blood. He was back in Washington six weeks before he was on Fourteenth Street looking for it. He was back eight months before he sold his grandfather's gilder's tip.

II. The Tape

Kenilworth House, Northeast · spring 1972

The house was a big tired frame house on a street of tired frame houses east of the Anacostia, a few blocks from Kenilworth Avenue. It had a porch with a swing on it and a back yard that ran down to a chain-link fence and a weedy lot, and eleven men lived in it, and a few women in the house next door, and none of them was allowed to leave for ninety days. It was not a hospital and not a jail and not a church. It was a house where people who had been on heroin lived together and told each other the truth until they could stand it. There were several like it in the city that year. This one belonged to Miss Odessa Bright, who owned the house outright and had started it in 1969 with her pension from thirty years of cleaning government offices at night, and who had not had a drink since the spring of 1946. She could have spent those years on her own porch, people said, and been entitled to them. She said she would keep the door open until the last one came through it, and she did not say who the last one was.

Calvin came in April, with a paper bag of clothes and a court letter. The man who took him in at the door was Bernard Hollins.

Bernard was thirty-eight and ran the house day to day. He had used for fourteen years and done two bids at Lorton, and he had been clean four years, and everybody in the house would have walked through a wall for him. He was patient and he was hard and he had a way of knowing which way a man was going to run before the man knew it himself. He looked at Calvin the first night, a good-looking boy, thin, with a jaw like his grandfather's and beautiful hands that would not keep still, and he thought

what he always thought about young ones. The want is strongest in the young. You had to put something in front of it.

What Bernard put in front of it was the tape.

Every morning, he told Calvin, *before you do anything, you sit down and you play the tape. Your worst one. All the way to the end. You don't stop it where it feels good. You run it right on through. The abscess on your arm. The man you saw dead in the bathtub on Swann Street. The time you came to with your face in the toilet in the Greyhound station. Your mama's face when the TV was gone. You look at it. You keep looking at it. That's the ugliness that's waiting for you if you go back out there. When the want comes up, you play the tape.*

It worked on most of them. Bernard had seen it work on a hundred men.

It did not work on Calvin. He sat on the edge of his bed every morning and tried. He could get the tape started, the bathtub, the toilet, his mother's face. But it would not run. It slid. His mind came off it the way a leaf of gold comes off dry glass, and he would find himself thinking about the light on the water stain on the ceiling, or the green of the paint on the window frame, or the way a blue jay's feather looked on the sidewalk outside, and the want would come up under all of it like water under a floor. He could not hold the tape for a minute together. For a month he could not hold it.

He told Bernard, because in that house you told. Bernard took him through it again, slower, with the whys and wherefores. Play it like a movie. Make it detailed. Smell it. Calvin tried for another two weeks and came back and said it slid. Bernard took him through it a third time, with examples, his own tapes, the worst things that had happened to him in fourteen years, things he had never said in a group. Calvin listened with his whole face and went away and tried and came back. It slid. It would not hold.

Bernard sat on the porch swing that night a long time by himself. He knew the boy was not lying. He knew what a lying man looked like. This one was trying, he was not off the path, he was working. And whatever was going on inside of him, Bernard could not see it.

In the morning he took Calvin into the kitchen to see Miss Odessa.

III. Miss Odessa

The kitchen · a morning in July

She was seventy-four. She was small and dark and straight-backed and wore a man's grey cardigan in all weathers, and her hair under a hairnet was white as cotton. She sat at the kitchen table in the mornings with a cup of coffee and a newspaper she did not read, and anybody in the house could come and sit across from her, and most of them did, sooner or later. She did not counsel. She did not run groups. She listened. People said she knew what was in a person the way you know what is in a jar by holding it up to the window, and nobody in the house, not even Bernard, knew how she did it. Bernard had said it to Calvin the first week. *I can see where a man is fixing to run. Miss Odessa can see what he's made of. That's hers. Don't ask me.*

Bernard told her the whole thing standing up, with his hands in his pockets: the tape, and three times through it, and the boy sliding off it, and three months nearly gone.

Miss Odessa looked at Calvin over her coffee for a long time.

Who are your people, baby?

He told her. He told her about his grandfather and the ledger and the shop on Ninth Street, the gelatin in the thermos, the squirrel-hair tip drawn across his cheek, the leaf that jumps up to the brush, the letters done backward on the inside of the glass so they read true from the street. He did not mean to tell her all of it. He found he was moving his hands while he talked, laying leaf in the air. He told her about the five hundred and eleven windows. He did not tell her about the black curls on the shard in the pharmacy, but she looked at his face and he understood she had seen that too.

When he was done she turned to Bernard.

You been giving this boy the ugly, she said. *The ugly works on you because you're a man who had to look at ugly to see it for what it was. This one's been looking at gold since before he could walk. His granddaddy, his daddy, his daddy's daddy, five hundred windows. Ugly won't stick to him. It slides right off. You can't lay leaf on a dry glass.*

Bernard said nothing for a minute. Then he nodded, slowly, like a man setting something down.

Go on, Bernard, she said. *Go see about the others. He'll come through it today. Before supper.*

Bernard looked at her, and at Calvin, and went.

IV. The Lotus

The back fence · the same morning

Miss Odessa got up from the table and went out the back door onto the porch and was gone about a minute. When she came back in she was carrying a lotus.

The cook, a big quiet woman named Mrs. Tolliver who had been at the stove the whole time, said afterward that it was as big across as a hubcap, on a stalk as long as a broom handle, and that it was dripping. Water ran off the leaves and the stalk onto the linoleum as if it had just come up out of a pond, and there was no pond nearer than the aquatic gardens a mile away, and Miss Odessa had not been gone long enough to walk to the end of the yard. That was one thing. The other thing was that it was gold. Not yellow, the way the wild lotuses in the gardens are yellow. Gold. Mrs. Tolliver had seen gold. She had a gold tooth and her mother's gold locket and she knew gold when she saw it, and she said that flower was gold all the way through, petals and pod and stalk, and threw the light off it onto the kitchen ceiling the way a window does in the late afternoon.

Miss Odessa put it in Calvin's hands.

It was heavy. It was cool. It was the color of the leaf in his grandfather's book when you first fold back the tissue, and his hands, which had not kept still in fifteen months, stopped moving. They held it the way they had once held the book of leaf: steady, not breathing. Something in his chest that had been running for a year and a half sat down.

There's a pile of sand by the back fence where they fixed the walk, Miss Odessa said. *Go on out there. Stick it in the sand, right by the fence, and sit down in front of it, and look at it. And say gold. Just that. Gold. When your mind goes off someplace, you bring it back and say gold.*

He went out the back door and down the yard to the end, where the chain-link fence was, and the lot beyond it, and the sand pile by the post. It was as far as you could go and still be in the house. He pushed the stalk down into the sand and it stood up. He sat cross-legged in the dirt in front of it like a boy, and looked at it, and said it.

Gold.

It was like the moment the water takes the leaf off the brush. That is the only way he could ever tell it afterward. There was a pull, and then he was flat on the glass. The yard was there, and the July heat, and a radio somewhere on the next street, and the buses going by out on Kenilworth Avenue, but all of it was a long way off and none of it was pulling at him. The want was down there under the floor, and he could feel it, and it did not come up. He said *gold* and looked at the flower and was glad.

After a while he did not need to say it. After a while longer the gladness went quiet too, the way the excitement goes out of the work when you have done a hundred letters and your hand knows them. Then there was nothing but the flower and his looking at it, even and still, like a sheet of glass in a frame with nothing written on it yet. He sat like that he did not know how long. The shadow of the fence post went from one side of him to the other. Bernard came to the back door twice and looked down the yard and went away again without a word.

V. The Pond

Kenilworth Aquatic Gardens · the afternoon

Mrs. Tolliver said that sometime after three o'clock Miss Odessa, who was sitting at the kitchen table with her coffee gone cold, looked out the window over the sink at the boy by the fence for a while and said, not to anybody, *That's far as he goes by himself. That's enough now.*

Down by the fence Calvin felt it before he saw it. The light changed. He looked, and the lotus was black.

It had not wilted. It had burned. The great gold petals had curled in on themselves and gone black and brittle at the edges, the stalk had sagged

in the sand, and the whole flower looked like something that had been through a fire and come out the other side. It looked like the three curls of leaf stuck to the shard in the window of the pharmacy on Fourteenth Street. It looked exactly like that.

He sat and looked at it, and he thought: *Gold did that.* Gold, that doesn't want anything. That doesn't need a fix, that doesn't need a woman or a dollar or a window with its name on it. Gold did that. And I want everything.

Then it went through him like the fire went up U Street. All of it, the windows and the ledger and his grandfather in his coffin on Georgia Avenue and the boy from Detroit and the vial and his own hands and his own face, was going the way the flower had gone, and none of it would stay, and none of it could be held, and none of it was his, and none of it ever had been, not even the boy sitting by the fence. He sat there with it burning in him, and he was afraid, and it was the first time in a year and a half he had been afraid of anything but being sick.

He got up. He did not decide to. He went out the gate in the fence and across the weedy lot and down to Kenilworth Avenue and across it, walking fast, the mile to the aquatic gardens, as if somebody had called him.

• • •

The ponds were full of lotuses. It was the third week of July, the high bloom, when the people who come out from the rest of Washington come out with cameras. There were not many that afternoon. The ponds lay in rows between dikes of mowed grass, all the way down to the marsh and the river, and in every one the lotuses stood up out of the water on their long stalks higher than a man's head, the big round leaves like green umbrellas turned inside out, and the flowers among them pink and white and pale yellow, as big as plates, and the seed pods like the spouts of watering cans.

Four boys from the neighborhood were in the pond nearest the gate, where they were not supposed to be, up to their waists in the brown water. They were snapping off lotuses and throwing them up onto the dike,

laughing, splashing each other, and there was already a pile of them on the grass.

Calvin stood on the dike and looked at the flowers in the pond, standing up out of the water with the water still running off them, every one of them perfect, and then he looked down at the pile on the grass by his feet. The boys had only been at it half an hour. Already the petals on the bottom of the pile had gone soft and brown at the tips, and curled, and the ones on top were starting. The sun was on them. In an hour they would all be like that.

He thought, *And those weren't even holding on to anything.*

He saw it then, all the way down, clearer than by the fence. The fire had gone out of it. It was only true.

VI. Lead Thou Me On

The dike · late afternoon

Something brushed his face. It was warm, like the light that comes off a window across the street when the sun gets low and finds it. He put up his hand and turned to see where it was coming from.

Miss Odessa was standing on the dike a few yards off, in her grey cardigan and her hairnet, with the pond and the lotuses behind her and the light coming off her the way it comes off gold leaf when it has been burnished right.

Mrs. Tolliver said afterward that Miss Odessa did not leave the kitchen table that afternoon, not once, from breakfast until she got up to set the table for supper, and Mrs. Tolliver would put her hand on the Bible to it. Bernard said he did not know anything about it and was not going to say. Calvin said she was there. He said he got up on his feet and put his hands together in front of him without knowing he was doing it, the way people do in church, and she smiled at him the way she smiled at people across the kitchen table, and she sang him a verse of a hymn, in an old woman's cracked voice that was not loud, that he had heard in his grandmother's church at Nineteenth Street when he was a boy and had not thought about since.

I was not ever thus, nor prayed that Thou
Shouldst lead me on;
I loved to choose and see my path; but now
Lead Thou me on.
I loved the garish day, and, spite of fears,
Pride ruled my will: remember not past years.

— John Henry Newman, "Lead, Kindly Light" (1833)

Then she talked to him the way she did, plainly.

Baby, it isn't the dope. You know that now. Dope's just what you were using to hold on with. It's you. It's that boy you've been taking care of all your life like he was the last window on U Street. You cut him loose. Like those children are doing yonder. With your own hand. Like a lotus at the end of summer. Then you go on.

And she sang the first verse, which everybody knows.

Lead, kindly Light, amid the encircling gloom,
Lead Thou me on;
The night is dark, and I am far from home;
Lead Thou me on:
Keep Thou my feet; I do not ask to see
The distant scene,—one step enough for me.

— "Lead, Kindly Light"

Calvin reached out with his hand into the pond and broke off a lotus at the stalk, the nearest one, a pale yellow one past its best, with its petals already starting to loosen. It came away easily. It made a small wet snap. He stood there on the dike holding it, and whatever it was in him that had been holding on, all those years, to the windows and the ledger and the vial and the boy, came away with it just as easily, and he let it go on the grass with the others.

When he looked up there was nobody on the dike but the four boys climbing out of the pond, and one of them was asking him for a cigarette.

He walked back to the house in time for supper. Bernard met him at the back door and looked at his face for a long time, the way he looked at

men to see which way they were going to run, and then put his arms around him, which he had never done to anybody in that house, and held on.

• • •

He stayed at Kenilworth House four years, the last three of them on staff, working beside Bernard. People said afterward that there was something about him the men who came in could not get around: he never seemed to want anything from them, not even for them to get well, and somehow that made them want to. When Miss Odessa died in 1979 he and Bernard carried her out the front door between them.

But before any of that, in the fall of 1972, he went to a sign shop on Rhode Island Avenue and spent forty dollars of the house's money on a book of leaf and a gilder's tip, squirrel hair, three and a half inches. Then he lettered the glass of the front door. He laid it out backward on a pattern and taped it on the porch side, and went inside and mixed the size in a coffee cup with water from the kettle, and flowed it on. He drew the tip once across his cheek and held it over the open book, and the leaf leapt up to it and hung there trembling, and he brought it to the wet glass, and the water took it.

KENILWORTH HOUSE. Gold, with a black shadow line. It read true from the street. He knew how long it would last, about as long as anything. He burnished it with a wad of cotton until Miss Odessa, standing on the porch, could see her face in it.

Background

The verse

> *Cut out the love of self, like an autumn lotus, with thy hand! Cherish the road of peace. Nirvana has been shown by Sugata (Buddha).*
>
> Dhammapada 285, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a handsome young goldsmith's son goes forth under the Buddha's chief disciple Sāriputta, who gives him the meditation on the impurity of

the body, since passion is strong in the young. The young monk cannot even fix his mind on it. Sāriputta teaches it to him three times, with reasons and similes, and finally brings him to the Buddha, who says that knowing another's inclinations belongs only to Buddhas. Seeing that the youth has been born into goldsmiths' families for five hundred lives, the Buddha makes a golden lotus as big as a cartwheel, dripping water, and tells him to set it in a heap of sand at the edge of the monastery and repeat "Red! Red!" The monk's mind settles through the four absorptions. Then the Buddha makes the flower wither and turn black, and the monk sees impermanence. Watching boys break lotuses from a pool and pile them on the bank, where they wilt at the tips, he sees it more clearly. A radiant image of the Buddha brushes his face and speaks the verse, and he is freed. Read the full commentary story.

Washington, D.C.

Washington, 1968–1972

By 1920 the U Street corridor was the center of Black Washington, called "Black Broadway," its theaters, churches, shops and offices lettered in the gold leaf that sign painters laid on the back of the glass, a craft related to the old art of verre églomisé. After Martin Luther King Jr. was killed on April 4, 1968, crowds gathered at Fourteenth and U, and four days of rioting and fire followed; about 6,000 troops were sent into the city, 13 people died and more than 6,100 were arrested (see the 1968 Washington riots). The corridor did not recover for decades. In May 1971 two congressmen came back from Vietnam reporting that some 15 percent of American servicemen there were addicted to heroin; that June the White House created a new federal drug office, and enlisted men were tested before they flew home (NPR's account of what happened to them afterward).

Kenilworth Aquatic Gardens, on the east bank of the Anacostia in Northeast Washington, began as a Civil War veteran's water-lily ponds in the 1880s and became a national park site in 1938. Its lotuses, including the yellow American lotus, peak in July. Recovery houses like the fictional Kenilworth House drew on the therapeutic community, a model of shared living, shared responsibility and plain talk that took

hold in American psychiatry and prisons in the 1960s. "Lead, Kindly Light" was written by John Henry Newman in 1833 and became one of the best-loved hymns in English (its history). The Pettaways, Kenilworth House, Odessa Bright and Bernard Hollins are fictional.

After the story of the Elder Suvaṇṇakāra from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 285). The original. Hymn text from John Henry Newman, "Lead, Kindly Light" (1833). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

20.10

Madder Red

To-morrow?—Why, To-morrow I may be
Myself with Yesterday's Sev'n Thousand Years.
— Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám XX

Word came up the trail, at Kid Village.

I. The Culvert

Bog Dam Road, White Mountain National Forest, New Hampshire · June 26, 2023

Big Rich had five hundred shirts in the van, counted, in eleven totes. He dyed nothing but red. He did it in a forty-gallon kettle behind his house outside Athens, Ohio, with madder root and alum, and he tied every shirt in the same tight spiral, so that on any Shakedown Street in the country people could say, *Those are Big Rich's reds,* from forty feet. He had sold on the lot since the spring tour of 1990. He was sixty-one years old, six foot four, and he had never in his life missed a show to go camping.

That summer Dead & Company were out on what they called the Final Tour. Rich had worked both nights at Fenway, and the lot had been fat. The plan was to drive west and be set up in Boulder by the first of July, then the Gorge, then the last three nights in San Francisco, where he meant to sell every shirt he had and think about what came after. But a kid buying a shirt at Fenway told him the Rainbow Gathering was in New Hampshire this year, three hours north, the first one ever in the White Mountains. Rich thought he could sell a hundred shirts to hippies in the parking area in two days and still make Colorado.

He drove through the night and came up Bog Dam Road at first light on Monday in a steady rain. A woman in a poncho leaned in his window

and said, *Welcome home.* He pulled the van onto a spur, across a little brook that was not on his map, and slept.

When he woke the brook had taken the culvert out behind him. There was a trench across the spur four feet deep with brown water going through it, and his van was on the wrong side.

It rained that day and the six days after. It was a wet year in New Hampshire, and the Forest Service had larger holes to fill than his. And the Family was keeping its holiday. People walked in past his van all week under tarps and trash bags, carrying drums, kettles, babies. Every one of them said *welcome home*, and not one of them bought a shirt. He had known there was no money inside a Gathering. He had not understood that they meant it. *Take them to trade circle, brother,* they told him. At trade circle a thirty-five-dollar shirt would get him a jar of honey or a piece of quartz. He had a storage unit in Ohio that did not take quartz.

In seven days he traded two shirts. He hung the wet ones on a line between two birches, and they did not dry.

II. The Bucket

The spur · Sunday, July 2

On Sunday morning a Forest Service crew came with a backhoe and a length of plastic pipe and filled the trench in an hour. Rich stood at his bumper and looked at the open road. It was twenty-nine hours to Boulder, and the shows there had started the night before.

He talked to himself when he was alone. Most people do who drive for a living.

Well, I've come a long way, he said. *If I turn around now I'm just late for everything. So I'll stay right here. I'll stay through the rain and work cleanup with these people till August, and they'll know me by then. I'll winter where they winter, in Florida, at Ocala. Next summer I'll come in early with my own kitchen, wherever they go, and sell in the towns along the way. A year. I'll move it all in a year.*

He liked it better the more of it he said. He began taking shirts off the line and wringing them out.

Two boys were coming down the spur toward the brook with a bucket. The big one was about nineteen, in a wool hat. The small one was seven and was called Early. He had been born at the Gathering in Vermont in 2016, in a tent at Kid Village, three weeks before anybody was ready. People in the Family held that a child born on the land was a little different. They said Early had told a woman from Tea Time that her dog would walk back in on Thursday, and it had.

Early looked at the tall man talking to his shirts, and he smiled.

What? said the big one, whose name was Nando. He was Early's half brother and had looked after him at every Gathering since he could carry him.

You see that man?

The red shirt guy. Sure.

He's saying where he's going to live all year, Early said. *He's got it all figured out. He's got a week.*

Nando stopped walking. *A week till what?*

Till he dies. Early said it in the voice he used for telling you your shoe was untied.

You sure?

Yeah. Saturday.

Nando looked at the man for a while. *Somebody ought to tell him.*

You go, said Early. *I'll get the water.*

III. Seven Days

Kid Village · July 2 to July 8

Rich had a camp stove going on his tailgate. He saw a wet kid with an empty cup and did what lot people do. He filled the cup with coffee and made him a peanut butter sandwich and did not ask what he wanted.

How long are you staying? Nando said, when he had eaten half.

Rich told him the whole plan. He told it well.

That's a good plan, Nando said. *Listen. It's hard to see it coming, for anybody. You should keep an eye out.*

For what?

My brother says you've got a week.

Who's your brother?

Nando pointed with the sandwich. Down at the brook a very small boy was holding a bucket in the current with both hands, leaning back against the pull of it.

Rich laughed. Then he stopped. He looked at the boy and the bucket for some time. He had been on the road thirty-three years and had heard every kind of talk, and he knew when a thing was not talk. He sat down on the tailgate.

A week, he said.

Saturday, said Nando. *I'm sorry, man.*

Rich sat there until the coffee was cold. Then he got up and asked where the children ate.

He drove out over the new culvert that afternoon, down to the Walmart in Gorham, and spent the Fenway money. It was twenty-three hundred dollars in a bank bag. He bought oats, rice, lentils, peanut butter by the case, oranges, bananas, cooking oil, coffee and two hundred pounds of potatoes. He brought it back up Bog Dam Road and carried it in to Kid Village a tote at a time, half a mile on a mud trail. The kitchen there was run by a woman called Mama Jo, who had said in 1989 that she would go home when the last kid was fed, and there had always been one more kid. She looked at the potatoes and handed him a peeler.

For seven days he cooked. He was up before light to start the oats. He hauled water, he fed the fire, and he scrubbed pots with ash and sand. At evening he helped carry the kettles down to Main Circle. There the whole Gathering stood in a ring in the meadow holding hands until the food came around, and afterward the Magic Hat went around for the next day's rice. He gave the shirts away. He gave them first to the children, and then to anyone who was cold, and that week it was nearly everyone.

On the Fourth the meadow was silent from sunrise. Fifteen or seventeen hundred people stood or sat in the wet grass without a word, under a sky as low as a tarp. At noon a sound started in the circle, one low note. Then the children came out of the trees from Kid Village in a line,

banging pot lids and singing. Every one of them was in a red spiral that hung to the knees. Early was near the front, with his sleeves rolled into doughnuts at his wrists. Rich stood at the edge of the meadow with a ladle in his hand. He had sold shirts for thirty-three years and had not once seen what they were for.

At night he lay in the van and listened to the rain on the roof and the drums a long way off. Water beaded on the empty clothesline outside his window, and each bead had a campfire in it.

IV. The Bowl

Kid Village · Saturday, July 8

The Gathering ends on the seventh, and on the eighth people walk out. That Saturday the rain held off. Early's mother had a shift in Brattleboro on Monday, and their packs were by the trail.

After breakfast Rich took Early's bowl from him and washed it. He did it carefully and dried it on his own shirt and gave it back. Then he sat down on a log, because he found he wanted to hear whatever there was.

Early stood in front of him holding the bowl. *You said you'd live here when it rains and when it snows and when it's hot.*

I did say that.

Don't say that. You don't get to pick that. You can say, I'm here.

I'm here, said Rich.

Yeah, said Early.

Kid Village kept a milk crate of books under the kitchen tarp, swollen with damp. Early could not read much yet. He went to the crate and took out a small one with no cover, opened it, and gave it to his brother with his thumb on the page. He had done this before. Nando had stopped being surprised at where the thumb was.

Nando read it out, standing, the way he would have read the directions on a box.

Think, in this batter'd Caravanserai
Whose Doorways are alternate Night and Day,
How Sultan after Sultan with his Pomp
Abode his Hour or two, and went his way.

Ah! my Beloved, fill the Cup that clears
TO-DAY of past Regrets and future Fears—
To-morrow?—Why, To-morrow I may be
Myself with Yesterday's Sev'n Thousand Years.

— Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám XVI, XX

Rich listened with his big hands hanging between his knees. He had made the plan on the spur six days before. He had wanted a place where they knew him, with a kitchen in it, and somebody to hand a peeler to. He had had exactly that since Sunday. None of it was owed to him next winter, and he found he was not asking for next winter.

Okay, he said. *Okay, little man.*

Mama Jo said afterward that he looked like a man who had set down two full totes.

V. The Trail Out

Kilkenny · the same day

He carried Early's pack for him up the trail as far as the first bend, where somebody had nailed a board to a spruce that said *WE LOVE YOU*. There he gave the pack back. Early put his arms through the straps and went on after his mother and Nando. He did not make anything of it.

Rich walked back down. At the kitchen he told Mama Jo he had something going on in his head, a kind of pressure, and that he thought he would lie down a while. He went out to the spur and lay down in the back of the van on the empty totes with the doors open. The medics from CALM found him there before dark. He had his boots off and set side by side on the bumper.

The cleanup crew stayed three weeks, as it always does, filling latrines and breaking up fire rings and raking the trails back into the woods. They took his line down last.

The next July the Family gathered in California. At Kid Village there were red spirals all over the meadow, on children from thirty states, and the shirts were a year closer to fitting.

Background

The verse

> *'Here I shall dwell in the rain, here in winter and summer,' thus the fool meditates, and does not think of his death.*
>
> Dhammapada 286, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the merchant Mahā Dhana ("Great Wealth") brings five hundred carts of safflower-red cloth to Sāvatthī and is stopped at the river by seven days of flood, while the city keeps holiday and nobody buys. He decides to stay the whole year, through rains, winter and summer, until his cloth is sold. The Buddha, passing on his alms round, smiles, and tells Ānanda that the man has seven days to live. Ānanda goes to the carts and tells him. The merchant feeds the Buddha and the monks for seven days, hears the verse, walks a little way with the Teacher, turns back with a pain in his head, lies down and dies. Read the full commentary story. The two verses Ānanda hears before he goes, on making an effort today because no one knows whether death comes tomorrow, are from the Bhaddekaratta Sutta.

Kilkenny, White Mountain National Forest, New Hampshire

Kilkenny, New Hampshire, 2023

The Rainbow Family of Living Light has met on National Forest land every July 1 to 7 since 1972. It has no leaders and no fees. Inside a Gathering almost no money changes hands: kitchens feed everyone, a "Magic Hat" is passed for supplies bought in town, and luxuries are bartered at a trade circle. Kid Village is the camp for families, CALM is the volunteer medical camp, and the outside world is called Babylon. On the morning of the Fourth the Gathering keeps silence and prays for peace; around noon the silence ends in a long Om, and a parade of children comes in from Kid Village. The 2023 Gathering was the first in the White Mountain National Forest, at the south end of the Kilkenny loop off Bog Dam Road, near Berlin and Gorham. It was a rainy summer, and attendance, at something over 1,700, was smaller than usual. The washed-out culvert, the people and the kitchen cook here are invented; Tea Time is a real Rainbow kitchen. The 2024 Gathering was held in northern California.

Dead & Company's Final Tour played Fenway Park on June 24 and 25, 2023, Boulder on July 1 to 3, the Gorge on July 7 and 8, and closed in San Francisco on July 14 to 16. The parking-lot market that follows the band is called Shakedown Street, after the Grateful Dead song. Madder root, fixed with alum, has dyed cloth red since antiquity. The quatrains are from Edward FitzGerald's first edition of the Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám (1859).

After the story of the merchant Mahā Dhana from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 286). The original. Verses from the Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám, translated by Edward FitzGerald (first edition, 1859). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

20.11

Dry Mustard

> *They did eat and drink, they bought and sold, they planted and built.*
> *— Luke 17:28*

Now I heard it like this, in the carports of Stonybrook.

I. The Jar

Montrose Street, South Philadelphia · 1936

Her grandmother told it every October, when the mustard greens came in at the Ninth Street market, and she told it the same way every time, sitting on the top step with a colander of beans in her lap.

There was a girl below Washington Avenue so thin the whole neighborhood called her Sicca, the stick. Some people said she had once picked coal out of a rich man's yard and it had turned to gold in her hands, but Nonna Gallo did not vouch for that part. She had been there for the other part. In the fall of the influenza Sicca's little boy died in her lap, and Sicca would not have it. She put him on her hip in his blue blanket and walked the neighborhood asking for medicine, and a nun at the school on Ellsworth Street, where they had made a hospital, told her the medicine was mustard seed. A pinch of it, from a house where nobody had ever died.

She came to me, Nonna Gallo said. *Your grandfather was four days dead. I had the black crepe on the door and she walked right past it. I went and got the jar. I had the jar in my hand, Rosalia, like this, and then she asked me. Has anybody died in this house.*

Rosalie was seven. She sat one step down and asked what she asked every year.

Did she find one?

Where would she find one? On Montrose Street? In my mother's house in Caltanissetta there were more dead than chairs.

So what happened to her?

She's a sister now. You've seen her, at the clinic, the thin one. Sister Antonia. She took the boy's name. Nonna Gallo snapped a bean in half and looked at the two ends. *That first sister was a hard one, to send a girl out like that. This one never sends anybody. Fifteen years in that clinic, and she never sent one.*

Rosalie thought about it on the step, and for a good while after. She did not say what she thought, because her grandmother would have laughed. She thought the trouble was the houses. Every house she knew was old. Three people had died in the front bedroom on Montrose Street alone, and the room knew it; you could tell by the way the door hung. Sicca had looked in the wrong place. Somewhere there had to be a house so new that nothing had happened in it yet, and that was where you would go, if you ever needed to.

II. Sparrow Lane

Levittown, Pennsylvania · 1952–1955

The house on Sparrow Lane was nine weeks old when Eddie Marino carried her over the sill of it. It smelled of paint and cut pine. It had three bedrooms on one floor, a kitchen with a General Electric range and a Bendix washer already standing in it, a carport, and a picture window that looked out on a square of raked dirt where Mr. Levitt's men had sown grass and staked one sapling the thickness of her thumb. There was no cellar. The heat ran in copper pipes through the floor itself, so that in January the boy would lie down flat on the kitchen tiles like a cat.

Eddie had been in the Navy, and a veteran could have the house for a hundred dollars down. He worked the open hearth at the new Fairless Works on the river, four to midnight most weeks, and came home with his eyebrows singed and slept until ten.

The year before, all of it had been spinach and broccoli. There were seventeen thousand houses going up on those fields, forty a day when the weather held, and there were six kinds, and on Sparrow Lane they were all one kind. The streets curved so that nobody could drive fast. Every street in Stonybrook began with an S. You could not put up a fence, and you could not hang wash on a Sunday, and you had to cut your grass once a week from April to November, and Rosalie did not mind any of it. Mr. Levitt sold to anybody who was white. That was in the papers too, and nobody on Sparrow Lane said much about it either way, which she would think about later, when she had started thinking about who was on the street and who was not.

The first night they had no bed yet. They put the mattress on the floor of the big bedroom and lay looking at a ceiling without one crack in it, and she thought, nobody has ever died in this room. Nobody had been sick in it, or born in it, or had a fight in it. She said so to Eddie, and he laughed and said give it time, and she hit him with the pillow.

Michael was thirteen months old that summer. He took his first steps without a hand to hold across the kitchen floor of that house, and he slept in the small bedroom she had papered with sailboats.

Her sisters came up on the train on Sundays to see the house. Her mother-in-law came, in her black coat, and walked through the rooms touching things. They opened the oven. They ran the water. *All on one floor,* her mother-in-law said, *like a hospital,* and she meant it kindly. They stood at the picture window and watched Mickey run on the lawn, and they told her she had everything, and she agreed with them. She had the house and the washer and a 1950 Plymouth and a husband who handed over his envelope on Fridays, and she had the boy, who was brown as a nut by July and had his father's ears. From the time she got up she was thinking about the grass and the slipcovers and the payment and his shoes. She thought about them the way you run a hand along a shelf to be sure everything is still on it.

She had never slept as she slept on Sparrow Lane. On Montrose Street there had been the trolley, and the Lombardos through the wall, and her grandmother coughing. Here there was a sprinkler somewhere, and then

nothing at all, and then morning. The whole street slept that way, four hundred houses with the lamps out.

III. The Glass

August 1955

That was the spring of Davy Crockett, and Mickey had the cap. Every boy on Sparrow Lane had the cap, a ring of fur with a striped tail down the back, a dollar and change at the five-and-ten, and he wore his to the table and to the bathtub and to bed. It was also the spring of the Salk shots. They lined the first and second graders up in the school gymnasium before the term let out, and the mothers on Sparrow Lane stood in the hall and cried, because it was over; another summer or two and nobody would have to keep a child out of the pool again. Mickey was four. The four-year-olds were to have theirs next.

The first storm came through on a Friday in the middle of August and rained itself out by Saturday noon. The lane was full of puddles. She let him out in them in his cap and his bathing trunks, and stood at the picture window with a cup of coffee and watched him stamp.

On Sunday he had a headache and would not eat. On Monday morning he could not bring his chin down to his chest, and when she gave him milk it came back out through his nose. The doctor came to the house and looked at him for less than a minute and went to the telephone in the hall.

They took him to the contagious hospital in the city, and there they took him through a door. She was not allowed through the door. There was a corridor with a window in it, and through the window she could see a row of tanks, long steel ones, each with a head at the end of it on a little shelf, and a mirror over each head. The fourth head was his. They had shaved a patch above his ear. The nurses wore masks, and they were not unkind, and they said no eleven times.

The cap could not go in to him either. Anything that went in would have to be burned after. So she kept it. She stood at the glass for four days with her pocketbook on her arm and the cap inside the pocketbook, and

Eddie stood beside her when he was not at the mill, and the tanks breathed. You could hear them through the wall, all together, like a ward of sleepers.

The second storm came up the coast on Thursday. It rained all that night on the hospital roof. At ten minutes to six on Friday morning a doctor came down the corridor with his mask pulled under his chin and said it to the two of them, and held out a clipboard, and Eddie signed where the doctor's finger was.

Rosalie did not sign anything.

She had not seen it. She had seen a tank through a pane of glass, with a small head at the end of it, and then a doctor's mouth moving. Anybody could say anything in a corridor. She had sat up with her grandmother. She had kissed her grandmother's forehead in the box in the front room on Montrose Street, with the mirror covered, and she knew what dead was. It was a thing in old houses. It was not a thing that came to a house with the paint still soft in the closets, and took a boy who had been stamping in a puddle on Saturday.

At home Eddie picked up the telephone to call Di Renzo, the undertaker on Dickinson Street who had buried all the Gallos, and she put her finger down on the cradle and held it there.

Ro.

Not yet.

He looked at her finger. He had been awake four days. *Monday,* he said. *I can give you till Monday.*

IV. The Pocketbook

Ellsworth Street, South Philadelphia · Saturday morning

She took the Plymouth and drove to the city with both hands on the wheel. The radio said the Delaware was out of its banks from Easton down and still rising, and that a creek in the Poconos had come up over a summer camp in the dark, and they did not have the count yet. She turned it off.

The clinic was where it had always been, in the ground floor of the old school, with the same green paint to the height of a child's shoulder. There were mothers on the bench with babies. Sister Antonia was at the scale. She was fifty-nine years old and looked like a clothes prop in a veil, and she weighed a baby and wrote the number on a card and gave the baby back before she looked up.

You're a Gallo, she said. *From across from the coal yard.*

Rosalie. I'm a Marino now. We're up in Levittown.

The Sister took her into the room behind, where there was a low table and some small chairs left from when it was a school. She sat down on one with her knees up and waited.

Rosalie stayed on her feet. She told it fast. The puddles, the milk, the glass, the tanks, the doctor with his mask down. She said they were saying her son was dead, and that she had not been let in to see for herself, and that she knew what the medicine was, because her grandmother had held the jar.

She did, said Sister Antonia. *She had it in her hand.*

So tell me to go and get it.

I never tell anybody that.

I know you don't. I know why. You think there isn't any such house. Rosalie heard her own voice going up, and let it go. *There wasn't, down here. There is now. I live in one. There are four hundred of them on my side of the parkway and the oldest is three years old. You can still smell the paint. Nobody has ever died in one of those houses, Sister. Three years ago it was spinach.*

Sister Antonia looked at her for a while. Then she looked at the pocketbook, which Rosalie had on her arm with her other hand flat over the clasp.

What have you got in the bag?

Nothing.

It looks heavy.

Rosalie went out past the mothers on the bench. The Sister did not get up and did not call her back, and for the rest of her life that was the nearest she came to sending anyone.

V. The Doors

Stonybrook · Saturday afternoon

SHE DID NOT GO INTO HER OWN HOUSE. SHE LEFT THE PLYmouth in the carport and took the tin measuring cup from the nail by the kitchen door, since a woman at your door with a cup in her hand needs no explaining, and went next door.

Peg Novak came to the screen with a dish towel on her shoulder. Her face changed when she saw who it was. Everybody on the lane knew; the ambulance had seen to that.

Peg, have you got any dry mustard? Just a little. A spoonful.

Honey. Sure I do. Come in. Sit down, for God's sake.

I have to ask you something first. Has anybody died in your house?

Peg laughed, once, out of fright. *In this house? It's the same as yours. They finished it the week before we came.* She went and got the mustard, a red and yellow can, and stood in the kitchen doorway turning it over in her hand. She and Stan had come down from Nanticoke when the collieries started closing. *My father,* she said. *A roof fall, in thirty-eight. They brought him home on a door. My sister's little girl, with the diphtheria. I don't know what made me think of them.* She put two spoonfuls in the cup. *That isn't here, though. That's all up home.*

At the Lerners' there was a little brass case on the doorpost and a card table in the living room with a jigsaw puzzle half done. Ruth Lerner was from the Bronx and kept her mustard in a crock. *Three years old, this house, the same as yours. Who would have died in it?* Then she was quiet for a moment. *Sol's family were from a town near Lublin. He has a list. It's in the drawer with the insurance papers, forty-one names, and he takes it out once a year. I don't know if you would say they died in this house.* She filled the cup to the half mark, far more than a spoonful. *I would say they live here.*

Maureen Pruitt had come over from Coventry in 1946 on a ship full of brides, and her mustard was in a yellow tin with a bull's head on it, the real kind, that took the roof off your mouth. *My mum and my gran. The fourteenth of November, 1940. One night, the both of them, and I was at the*

pictures. She said it lightly, the way she said everything, and her hand shook, and mustard went on the step.

Betty Kovach was from Donora, out past Pittsburgh. Her husband had followed the steel east. *The smog,* she said. *October of forty-eight. It sat down on the town for five days, you couldn't see the porch rail from the door. My pop was one of the twenty. He had the asthma already.* She looked past Rosalie at the lane, the wet lawns, the sky washed clean by the storm. *That's why I like it here. You can see.*

The Hallorans had a photograph on top of the television set, a boy in a Marine uniform with his cap too big for him. Korea, the first winter. Mrs. Halloran did not say anything about it. She saw Rosalie look, and she went and got the mustard.

At the house on the bend a girl of twenty came to the door with a baby on her shoulder and said no, nobody, they were all fine, thank God. She filled the cup from a jar. Rosalie was at the foot of the walk when the girl called after her. *There was one before Linda. A boy. He lived two days.* She shifted the baby. *We never had a picture taken. I never told anybody on this street that. I don't know why I'm telling you.*

A man in his undershirt, on the night turn, got up out of his sleep to answer the bell. Eleven men, he said, in a wood in Germany, in one afternoon. He did not have any mustard. He stood on his step in his bare feet and said all eleven names anyhow, and then he said he was sorry for her trouble and went back to bed.

She went on. Sparrow Lane, Spindle Lane, around the long curve and back. Nobody refused her. They filled the cup until it would hold no more and then they pressed the cans and jars on her, so that she was carrying them in the crook of her arm against the pocketbook. Not one of them had a death in the house, and every one of them stopped in the doorway and told her who they had brought with them.

VI. The Lamps

Sparrow Lane · evening

By seven the light had gone long and yellow. Somebody's sprinkler was going on a lawn that could not have needed it, after two storms, ticking around and around. She stood in the middle of Sparrow Lane where it bent, with the cup in one hand and four cans of mustard in her arm, and the lamps began to come on.

Every house had one. It was the same lamp, or near enough, on the same table, in the middle of the same window, and they came on one after another down the curve of the lane as the women went to them. She had looked at those lamps for three years and seen a new street full of young people.

She saw the street now. There was a miner laid on a door in the Novaks' living room. There were forty-one people from a town near Lublin at the Lerners' card table. An old man from Donora sat on the Kovaches' davenport trying to get his breath, and two women from Coventry stood in a kitchen, and a boy who had lived two days was in the house on the bend, and eleven soldiers were in the house where the man had gone back to sleep. They had come up in the moving vans with the lamps and the bedsteads. They had come over on the ships. In every one of those windows the dead outnumbered the living, three to one, ten to one, and it was so in the new streets going up beyond the parkway and in the old ones on the far side of the river, in the Bronx and Nanticoke and Coventry, and on Montrose Street, and in Caltanissetta where there were more of them than chairs. It was so on Lombard Street, where her grandmother used to buy greens from a colored woman with a tub garden, and where nobody had been handed a hundred-dollar house. The fields under her feet had been somebody's before they were spinach. She had thought there was a kind of house it could not find. There had never been any such house. There had only been three years, and a street that slept well.

The pocketbook was pulling at her shoulder. It had been pulling since Monday, and she had not let herself feel it.

She went up her own walk. Eddie was at the kitchen table in the dark with his hands around a cup of coffee gone cold. She set the cans down on the drainboard one at a time, and the measuring cup, heaped and yellow, and then she picked up the telephone and held it out to him.

Call Di Renzo, she said. *Tell him Michael Edward Marino. Tell him he was four in June. I want to go down with you and see him. I want the blue suit, and I want it open.*

Eddie took the telephone out of her hand as if it might break, and dialed.

VII. The Small Chairs

Ellsworth Street · Tuesday

THEY BURIED HIM FROM ST. PAUL'S ON CHRISTIAN STREET, where she had been baptized, and took him out to Holy Cross, where the Gallos had a plot. Half of Sparrow Lane drove down for it in a line of cars with their headlights on. Beyond the Gallo stone there was a long piece of ground with grass on it and no stones at all, and she saw Sister Antonia, who had come out on the trolley, stand at the edge of that ground for a minute by herself before she came over to the grave.

Afterward Rosalie left Eddie with her sisters and walked to Ellsworth Street in her black dress. The clinic was closed for the afternoon. The Sister was in the back room washing bottles, and she dried her hands and sat down on one of the small chairs, and this time Rosalie sat too, knees up, across the low table.

Did you get the seed?

No, Sister. I got mustard. I have nine cans of mustard on my drainboard. She found she could almost laugh, and then could not. *The houses are three years old, and in every one of them the dead are more than the living. They brought them along. I never knew it. I lived on that street three years and I never knew who was in those houses.*

You thought it was only you, said Sister Antonia. *Everybody thinks so. I thought so for a whole day, from Montrose Street to Race Street, with him on my*

hip. She said the next part quietly, looking at the table, the way you would read someone the hours off a door.

> *Fear not the sentence of death. Remember what things have been before thee, and what shall come after thee: this sentence is from the Lord upon all flesh.*
>
> *— Ecclesiasticus 41:5*

We had everything, Rosalie said. *Everybody told me so. I counted it every morning.*

I know you did.

> *They did eat and drink, they married wives, and were given in marriage, until the day that Noe entered into the ark: and the flood came and destroyed them all. Likewise as it came to pass, in the days of Lot: they did eat and drink, they bought and sold, they planted and built.*
>
> *— Luke 17:27–28*

That's hard, Sister. They weren't doing anything wrong. Planting and building.

Where does it say they did wrong? It says they were busy. It says the water came while they were counting. The Sister folded the dish towel in four. *You're awake now. It costs what it costs. Stay awake.*

Rosalie opened the pocketbook. She had not opened it in eight days, not for a handkerchief, not at the grave. She took out the cap and laid it on the low table between them, with the tail straight. It was smaller than she remembered. It smelled of his head.

Sister Antonia did not touch it. She looked at it for as long as Rosalie did.

You can take that home again, she said. *Hang it where it hung. There's no rule against it. It will weigh what a cap weighs.*

• • •

The river went down that week and left its mud in the towns upstream. On Sparrow Lane the women came across the lawns, one or two at a time.

They brought a ham and a tray of stuffed cabbage and a noodle pudding and a trifle in a glass bowl, and they stayed. Ruth Lerner brought the list out of the drawer one afternoon and read Rosalie all forty-one names at the kitchen table. The girl from the house on the bend told her the boy's name, which was Thomas. Rosalie wrote them down. By October she had a page for every house she had knocked at, and the women on Sparrow Lane had started coming to her kitchen when there was something they could not say in their own.

She kept the nine cans in a row on the sill over the sink. The cap went back on its hook by the carport door.

She did not sleep as she had. Most nights she got up around two, when the furnace was off and the house was still, and went and sat in the chair by the picture window. The lane lay out in front of her in its long curve under the streetlights, every lawn cut, every window dark, four hundred houses breathing together. She sat with all of them, the ones in the beds and the ones who had come along in the vans. Then she reached over and turned on the lamp.

Background

The verse

> *Death comes and carries off that man, praised for his children and flocks, his mind distracted, as a flood carries off a sleeping village.*
>
> Dhammapada 287, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary tells the story of Kisā Gotamī twice. The long telling belongs to verse 114. This second, short one returns to the moment she comes back empty-handed. Her child had died, she would not believe it, and she went about looking for a cure until someone sent her to the Buddha, who asked for a pinch of mustard seed from a house where no one had died. "In the entire village the dead are more in number than the living," she reports. He answers that she was wrong to imagine she alone had lost a child, that death sweeps all beings away like a torrent with their longings unfulfilled, and he speaks verse 287. Read the full commentary story, or about Kisā Gotamī. The series told the long version as The Mustard Seed; the girl called Sicca in that story is the Sister in this one.

Levittown, Pennsylvania

Levittown, Pennsylvania, 1955

Levittown was built by Levitt & Sons between 1952 and 1958 on 5,750 acres of Bucks County spinach and broccoli farms, beside the new Fairless Works of U.S. Steel. The first family moved into a house on Stonybrook Drive on June 23, 1952. When building stopped there were more than 17,000 houses in six models, set on concrete slabs with radiant heat in the floor, along curving streets whose names share the first letter of their neighborhood. Veterans could buy with almost nothing down. Buyers came from Philadelphia row-house neighborhoods, from the declining anthracite towns and from the steel valleys of western Pennsylvania. Early rules forbade fences and Sunday wash lines. Levitt refused to sell to Black families, and when William and Daisy Myers bought a house in Levittown in 1957 they met weeks of mob harassment. The Encyclopedia of Greater Philadelphia has more.

The results of the Salk polio vaccine trial were announced on April 12, 1955, and the first shots went to young schoolchildren that spring, so the summer of 1955 was among the last in which American parents feared the disease as they had for decades. In August two storms crossed the region five days apart. The second, Hurricane Diane, caused the worst floods then on record in eastern Pennsylvania; Brodhead Creek in the Poconos overran a summer camp and killed 37 people, most of them children. The neighbors' dead are drawn from real events: the Donora smog of October 1948, which killed twenty people in a steel town near Pittsburgh, and the bombing of Coventry on the night of November 14, 1940. The Marinos, their neighbors, Sparrow Lane and the clinic on Ellsworth Street are fictional.

After the story of Kisā Gotamī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 287). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

20.12

The Children's House

So when thou art relieved, still toil
And strive to please thy Lord.
— Qur'an 94:7–8

The old people told it so, on the Altamaha.

I. The Driver's Daughter

Tarbert plantation, on the Altamaha, McIntosh County, Georgia · 1817–1823

TENAH WAS FIVE THE YEAR THE DRIVER'S DAUGHTER CAME across from the Island in a stolen canoe, and it was the first thing in her life she remembered whole.

The Island was the cotton place, out past the marsh where the river met the salt. The same family owned it that owned Tarbert, and everybody at Tarbert knew about the driver there. He was a Fula man named Samba who had come by way of the Bahamas, tall, with a red cap. He prayed on a mat three times a day with his face to the east, and ran two hundred hands for old Mr. McAllan with nothing but his voice. He lived in a tabby house with a plank floor and a sleeping loft, the only loft in any quarter on that coast, and he kept his daughters up in it. He meant them for men of his own faith. There were some. There were more on Sapelo, under the old driver there, and Samba had promised his girl Medina to a boatman of that place, a man who could say his prayers.

Medina wanted Cato, who was a ditcher at Tarbert and could say no prayers at all. She had seen him twice, when the flats went over with seed rice. She took a canoe in the dark of the moon and came nine miles through the creeks on the flood tide, and she was sitting on the landing

at Tarbert when the horn blew, seventeen years old, with her feet cut by oyster shell.

The overseer could have sent her back with stripes. He wrote to the old man instead, and the old man said a contented wench was worth two in the sulks and to leave her where she had lit. Her father sent word by the boatmen that he had four daughters now and not five.

She did not know how to do anything. Tenah remembered that. The women in the street watched her try to beat rice in the mortar and get the pestle going crooked, and they laughed until they had to sit down, and then they showed her. They showed her how to fan it in the wide basket and let the wind take the chaff. They showed her how to stand in the field with the water at her shins and not think about what else was standing in it. She learned. She worked her quarter acre with the rest. But she carried her head like a driver's daughter all the same, and she never did come to sit on a step in the evening and talk, and people held it against her a little, in an ordinary way.

Her boy Sam was born the next year. Twice she sent word across to the Island that there was a grandchild, and twice nothing came back.

Cato was mending the bank by the lower trunk in August of 1823, up to his thighs in the ditch, when he put his hand on a moccasin. He walked back to the street on his own legs. By dark his arm was the size of his thigh and black to the shoulder, and he died before the tide turned. Medina was four months gone with the second child. She did not scream. She washed him herself and would let no one help her.

The baby came at Christmas, another boy. By then Tenah was eleven and a nurse girl at the children's house, and they gave him to her to carry.

II. The Pencil

Tarbert · spring 1824

THE CHILDREN'S HOUSE STOOD AT THE HIGH END OF THE street, on the shell bluff. All the children too small to work stayed there in the day under Maum Kadi, and four or five nurse girls helped her, and three times between sunup and dark each girl took her baby on her hip

AND WALKED OUT ALONG THE BANKS TO WHEREVER ITS MOTHER was hoeing, so it could be fed.

Maum Kadi was older than anybody. She had been a grown girl when they took her, on a road in a country she called Futa, where her father had kept a school and taught boys to write on boards. She kept a white cloth over her head and a long string of beads in her bosom. She prayed when Samba prayed, sunrise and noon and sunset, on a square of rice sacking behind the house. On one day in the year she soaked rice overnight and beat it to paste with honey and patted it into flat cakes, and she called the children in a row and put a cake in each one's two hands and said a word over it, and they said *Ameen* because she had taught them to, and ate. She did not talk much. Women brought her their trouble on the step in the evening anyhow, since she would hear all of it and usually say one thing.

The old master died that winter in Savannah. In April his factor came up the river in a sloop with a paper.

He had the driver stand every child on the place between six and twelve along the landing. He walked down the row with a pencil. He was a neat man in a gray hat, and when he stopped in front of a child he put two fingers under its chin and turned its face to the light. Tenah stood in that row with Medina's baby on her hip. He stopped in front of her. He looked at her, and at the baby, and at the yaws scars on her shins, and he wrote something and went on.

He took nine. Sam was the smallest. He had just had his sixth birthday, if a child born at Tarbert could be said to have one.

The women were not allowed on the landing. They stood up on the bluff with the driver in front of them. When the sloop cast off, Medina went through the driver as though he were a gate left open, and down the bluff and into the river. She waded out until it was at her waist and threw both arms up over her head and screamed at the boat. She screamed three times. The man in the gray hat was sitting on a keg in the stern with the paper on his knee, and he did not look around. Sam did. Then the sloop came into the current and went down toward Darien.

Tenah watched it from the landing. The baby was heavy on her hip and she held him so hard he cried. She was thinking that the pencil had stopped in front of her, and that there was no reason she knew of why it had moved on.

III. The Water

Tarbert · Tuesday, September 14, 1824

THE RICE WAS CUT. IT LAY IN THE FIELDS ON ITS OWN STUBBLE to dry, a whole year of it, and another two days would have seen it tied and stacked.

All that Tuesday afternoon the sky was the color of a pot bottom, and the wind blew steadily out of the northeast with rain in it. The old people did not like the look of the tide, which came up at the ebb when it should have been going down. At dark the driver sent everybody into the rice barn on the bluff, the one building at Tarbert with a second floor, and the overseer went up the river road on his mule and was not seen until Thursday.

By the time a person could have walked to the lower trunk and back, it was blowing harder than Tenah had known wind could blow. It made a noise like surf on a bar. The river came up over the banks and over the fields and took the cut rice off the stubble all at once, like a cloth pulled from a table. Then it came up the bluff. It came into the street and through the cabins, and the cabins began to go.

There were a hundred and sixty people in the loft of the rice barn in the dark. Tenah lay against her mother with the floor shaking under her. Maum Kadi sat by the ladder hole with five babies in her lap and against her knees. She was saying something over and over, low, and passing the beads through her fingers.

Medina was not in the loft.

She had gone back down to her cabin for something. Nobody ever found out what it was. She had the baby tied on her back in her blue wrapper, and when the water came through the street she got to the big

live oak behind the children's house and climbed. A man in the barn door saw her go up by the lightning.

Near midnight the wind stopped. It did not ease. It stopped, and for as long as it takes to shell a basket of peas there was no sound at all except water running. In that quiet they heard her from the oak. She was calling a name, the same one, over and over, and it was the baby's. She kept asking somebody to look. She kept saying the cloth had come open.

Then the wind came back from the other side and blew until almost morning, harder than before.

Day came up mild and clear. The street was gone. There were six cabins standing of thirty-one. The fields were a lake with nothing on it, and the banks were cut in forty places. Eleven people at Tarbert were dead, and Medina's baby was one of them. They found him two days later in the marsh wrack with the rice straw. Medina was sitting in the fork of the oak with the empty wrapper around her shoulders, and it took two men to bring her down.

IV. The Landing

Tarbert · that week

On Thursday a boat came up from the Island for meal. The boatman was an old man called Ishmael who had carried Medina's two messages across, years before, and carried back nothing. She was at the landing before he had his line fast.

Uncle. You come from the Island.

I come from where it was.

The tabby house by the cotton barn. The driver's house.

He busied himself with the line. *Daughter, don't ask me about that house. Ask me about any other house on the Island, and I'll tell you.*

I don't care about any other house.

Tenah was on the bluff with the other nurse girls, and she saw the old man stand up straight in his boat and take off his hat.

The sea came over the Island six feet deep, he said. *Samba put every soul on the place up in the cotton house before dark and counted them in. Then he went*

back for your mother. She would not leave the house without something of hers. Your brother Hamadi went after the two of them. The wave took the east wall and the loft came down on all three. We dug them out Wednesday. We put them in the sand together with their faces the way he would have wanted. He pointed down the river, where a brown smoke stood over the marsh. *That's the cattle. Four hundred head drowned, and they are burning them on the beach. It was after the burying. I would not have you think otherwise.*

Medina looked at the smoke.

She did not fall down. That was what frightened Tenah. She turned around and walked up off the landing, and the blue wrapper slid from her shoulders and lay on the planks, and she walked out of it. Her other cloth had been rotting on her since the oak. By the time she reached the top of the bluff it had gone too, and she did not know it. She walked out along what was left of the main bank with nothing on, and around the square of the first field, and back, and around. She was talking.

One of my boys the hawk took. One the water took. My husband is dead of the snake. My mother and my father and my brother lie under one wall.

She said it all day. She said it the next day. She did not come when the horn blew, and there was work at Tarbert that week for every hand on the place and the half-hands too, and for the children. The driver went out to her with the strap and came back without using it. He said there was nobody there to whip.

People would not have her near them. It was not hardness. Every person on that bluff had somebody under the mud or down the river in a sloop, and she was saying it out loud, around and around, and they could not stand to hear it said. They told her to get away. They said she would bring the rest of it down on them.

The children threw mud. There was plenty of it, the whole place was mud, gray and stinking, and you could pick it up anywhere. Tenah threw first. She was twelve years old. She had carried that woman's baby on her hip for nine months, and she picked up a double handful of marsh mud and threw it as hard as she could, and it hit Medina between the shoulders and stuck. After that they all did.

Medina never turned her head.

V. The Step

The children's house · Saturday, sunset

THE CHILDREN'S HOUSE HAD STOOD. IT WAS ON THE HIGHEST of the shell, and the water had only come to its sill. Half the street was sleeping in it and under it, and in the evening they sat about the step, for there was nowhere else to sit.

Maum Kadi had finished her sunset prayer and come around to the front with her beads in her hand. She saw Medina a long way off, coming along the bank against the red sky with a crowd of children behind her.

Tenah was in that crowd. She had mud in both hands.

The people at the step stood up. *Maum, don't let her in here among the babies. She's gone in her head. Somebody turn her.*

Let her come, said Maum Kadi. *Move out of her road.*

They moved. Medina came up the shell path saying it, *one the hawk took, one the water took,* and stopped at the foot of the step, because the step was in front of her and there was an old woman on it.

Maum Kadi spoke to her. It was only a few words, and Tenah did not understand them. Nobody there did, except the one they were said to. They were in the language of Futa, which Samba had spoken in the tabby house and nowhere else, and which Medina had not heard in seven years.

The ones who were at the step that evening told about it as long as they lived. They said the woman's eyes had been open all week with nobody behind them, and that when the old woman spoke, somebody came and stood behind them again. She looked at the people. She looked down at herself. She made a sound and went down on the shell with her arms around her knees and her head between them.

Tenah dropped the mud. She did not decide to. She had on a blue wrapper of her own, her mother's, cut down, and she pulled it loose from her waist and went forward and put it over the woman's back. She stood there in her shift with her hands empty and stinking.

Medina got the cloth around her. She crawled the rest of the way to the step and laid her forehead on Maum Kadi's feet.

Mother. Help me. One of my boys the hawk took, the man in the gray hat. One the water took out of the cloth on my own back. Cato is dead of the snake. The wall fell on my mother and my father and my brother, and my father never sent me one word.

Maum Kadi heard it to the end. Then she laid her hand on the woman's head, mud and all.

All of that is so, she said, in English, so that the step could hear. *Now be still. You have come where you can be still. You think you are the first. I cried on the ship. Every woman on that ship cried, and every woman on every ship before it and since, and the ones left standing on the shore. Put all that crying in one place, daughter, and it is more than the salt water we were carried over. You have been crying a long time. Longer than you have been alive, I think. Rest from it a little.*

She said nothing else that night. She had Tenah bring a piggin of water, and she washed the mud from Medina's back with her own hands, and put her to sleep on the floor among the babies.

VI. The Day of the Cakes

The children's house · October 1824

Medina went to the field on Monday with the rest and shoveled mud back into the breaks. She did her task. At night she slept in the children's house. She cried when she had to, quietly, and Maum Kadi let her, and waited.

It was better than three weeks. The day for the cakes came round, and there was no honey on the place and little enough rice, but the old woman had put by a gourd of each on the rafters, and they had ridden out the water there. She soaked the rice overnight. In the morning Medina took the pestle from her without being asked and beat it, with the stroke the women of the street had taught her, and the children held out their hands in a row and said their word.

That evening the two of them sat on the step. Tenah was inside the door with a baby asleep on her, and other women were about, mending.

You are lighter, Maum Kadi said.

A little.

Then you can hear me. I would not say it to you before. She had her beads in her lap, and she did not look at Medina but out at the fields. *Your father could not keep you. He built a loft to keep you in, and he could not. You could not keep your sons. You tied one to your back with a good knot. Cato could not keep himself. This is not because you are a slave. The man in the gray hat thinks it is his paper that parts us. He thinks he wrote that. People were parted before there was any paper. There are kings in Futa with a hundred sons, and when the hour comes for one of them, not one son can go in his place or go with him. The Book says it.*

She said it first as it was written, in a language none of the women on the step knew, and it sounded like water going over a trunk gate. Then she put it into plain words for them, and Tenah, inside the door, got those by heart without trying.

> *O mankind! Keep your duty to your Lord and fear a Day when the parent will not be able to avail the child in aught, nor the child to avail the parent. Lo! Allah's promise is the very truth. Let not the life of the world beguile you, nor let the deceiver beguile you, in regard to Allah.*
>
> *— Qur'an 31:33*

So I must not lean on them, said Medina.

Love them. I love my father yet, and it is fifty years. But you cannot stand on them. Nobody can. What you can stand on is what you do with your own two hands between now and your own hour, and that hour is not far off for anybody on this river. So don't sit. You have been eased a little. Get up and clear your road while you can see it.

> *But lo! with hardship goeth ease,*
> *Lo! with hardship goeth ease;*
> *So when thou art relieved, still toil*
> *And strive to please thy Lord.*
>
> *— Qur'an 94:5–8*

Nobody on the step said anything. A woman named Binah, who had two children in the same sloop as Sam, put down her mending and wiped her face with the back of her wrist, and after a moment took the mending up again and went on with it, and her needle was steadier than it had been since April.

Tenah sat inside the door. The baby on her chest breathed in and out. She thought of her own mother, who was down the street in one of the six cabins, and she understood that her mother could not have stopped the pencil, and that she would never be able to stop anything for her mother. It did not make her love her mother less. It made her want to get up. She laid the baby down in its box and went and found the broom.

Teach me the washing, Medina said on the step. *My father would have taught me. I didn't stay for it.*

VII. The Gourd

Tarbert · afterward

Before sunup the next morning Tenah was sent to the well with the piggin and the dipping gourd. She carried them around behind the children's house. The square of rice sacking was laid out on the shell, and beside it now there was a second.

Pour for her, said Maum Kadi.

Medina held out her hands. Tenah poured from the gourd. The water ran over the two hands and off the fingers onto the shell and was gone into it. Maum Kadi said to do it again, and she poured again, and a third time. Then the mouth, three times. Then the face. Then the right arm to the elbow and the left. The old woman said the order of it, and Medina did it, slowly, like someone learning to beat rice. The light was coming up gray over the broken fields, and every time the water ran off into the shell Tenah watched where it went.

Then the two women stood on their sacking with their faces to the place where the sun would rise, toward the marsh and the Island and the salt water, and Tenah took the empty gourd back to the house, since the babies would be waking.

• • •

Medina kept the children's house after Maum Kadi, for twenty-two years. She never left a child alone with its trouble and never told one a thing that was not so. Tenah kept it after her. She was not of their faith and did not pray on sacking. She was baptized in the river at forty by a Baptist exhorter, and was content with that. But she would not pick up a newborn, hers or anybody's, until someone had poured water over her hands three times, and the girls who poured for her learned to do it without asking why.

She was fifty-three and still at Tarbert in the winter that freedom came up the river. She had her hands held out over the piggin when the shouting started down the street, and a girl of twelve was pouring.

Again, Tenah said. *Go on. That's two.*

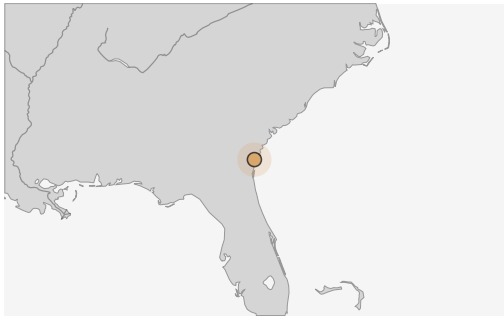
Background

The verses

> *Sons are no help, nor a father, nor relations; there is no help from kinsfolk for one whom death has seized.*
>
> Dhammapada 288, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *A wise and good man who knows the meaning of this, should quickly clear the way that leads to Nirvana.*
>
> Dhammapada 289, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary tells the life of Paṭācārā at length under verse 113: a rich man's daughter who ran off with a servant and then lost her husband to a snake, one son to a hawk, the other to a river, and her parents and brother under a fallen house, all within a few days. She went mad and wandered naked, driven off with clods, until the Buddha told her to come back to her right mind. This second, short entry returns to what he said next. Seeing that her grief had eased, he told her that neither sons nor kin can be a shelter for anyone at death, and that the wise therefore lose no time in clearing their own path. She and many who were listening were changed by it. Read the full commentary story, or about Paṭācārā. The series told the long version as Spilt Water, set in another storm on another shore.



McIntosh County, Georgia

The Georgia rice coast, 1824

A good many of the West Africans enslaved on the Georgia and Carolina sea islands were Muslims, often Fula people from Futa Jallon in what is now Guinea. The best documented is Bilali Mohammed, head driver on Thomas Spalding's plantation on Sapelo Island, who left a thirteen-page Arabic manuscript on belief, ablution and prayer. In the 1930s his great-grandchildren told interviewers for *Drums and Shadows* that he and his wife prayed on a mat at sunrise, noon and sunset with a long string of beads, and that a grandmother who "come by Bahamas" made flat cakes of pounded rice and honey called *saraka* on the same day each year and put one in every child's hands. The descendants of these communities are the Gullah Geechee people.

Tidewater rice was grown in diked fields flooded and drained through wooden gates called trunks, and worked by the task. Infants were minded in a children's house by an old woman and young nurse girls. Children could be sold away from their mothers, and often were when an estate was settled. On the night of September 14, 1824, a major hurricane came ashore near Darien and St. Simons Island at harvest. The eye passed over Darien around midnight, the sea swept across the islands, and well over a hundred people drowned, many of them enslaved; the surviving reports are collected by plantation. Tarbert, the Island and everyone on them are fictional. The Fula words spoken on the step are left unquoted, and the Qur'an is given in Marmaduke Pickthall's English of 1930.

After the story of Paṭācārā from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 288 and 289). The original. Scripture from the Qur'an, translated by Marmaduke Pickthall (1930). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 21

Miscellaneous

21.1

Toussaint

> *That which the fountain sends forth returns again to the fountain.*
> *— Longfellow, Evangeline (1847)*

C'est comme ça que moi je l'ai entendu, on Bayou Lafourche.

I. Three Dangers

The Chênière · October 1893

Before the storm there were fifteen hundred people on the Chênière and four hundred and fifty houses, and on a Sunday you could hear the church bell from Grand Isle across the pass. The men tonged oysters and dragged seines for shrimp and sailed the catch up through Barataria to the lugger landing across from New Orleans. The women kept gardens of okra and mirliton behind the houses, and there were orange trees and a little cane, and live oaks along the ridge so old that the ridge had its name from them. People came down from the bayou to marry there and stayed.

The storm came in the night of the first of October with no warning anyone had heard. The water rose six feet in a few minutes and then rose two more. All night the church bell rang by itself in the wind, and the people in the water turned toward the sound of it. In the morning four houses were standing.

Seven hundred and seventy-nine people were dead. That was the count they gave the newspapers later, and the people who were left said it was short. Sixty-two had lived through the night under what was left of a single roof. Others had held onto doors and pieces of gallery and drifted, and some of them came back. The dead were in the lagoons and in the

marsh grass and in the branches of the oaks. The men who could still stand buried what they could find in long trenches on the ridge and in the ruin of the graveyard, and there were more than they could find.

Then the hunger came, because the gardens were salt and the boats were kindling and the flour in the barrels had turned to paste. The relief luggers from New Orleans came within the week with flour and coffee and men to help bury, and went back, and came again, and it was never enough. Then the sickness came, the bloody flux, out of the water they had to drink, and the old ones and the little ones who had lived through the storm began to die of that. And at night there were lights in the marsh. Everyone saw them. They were the feux follets, the little fires that walk over wet ground where the dead are, and they came up to the edge of the ridge and stood there, and the dogs would not stop crying, and a woman who went out to the trenches after dark to pray for her husband came back without her voice and did not get it back.

So there were three dangers on the Chênière: hunger, and sickness, and the dead who would not lie down.

The men met in the Rigaud house, which was one of the four. Old Théodule Rigaud kept the store, or had kept it, and had been something like the head man of the place for thirty years, and he stood up in front of them with his hat in his hand and said, *If this has come on us for something I did, say it. I'll go.* They went over his life, all of it, out loud, the way people can only do in a place that small, his dealings and his debts and his wife and the matter of the fence in 1871, and at the end they said they could not find it in him. It was not that.

They had already done everything they knew. They had said the rosary on the ridge every evening. They had carried a statue of the Virgin around the trenches in procession. They had made a novena. Some of them now wanted to send to New Orleans for the doctors of the Board of Health, and some for a famous healer over on the Teche, and some for a holy woman down in Plaquemines whom nobody had actually seen.

Then somebody said Tante Zélie.

Everyone on Bayou Lafourche knew Azélie Gautreaux. She was a traiteuse, and she had treated half of them or their mothers, for burns

and for sunstroke and for the bleeding that will not stop and for the thing in the chest that the doctors could not name. She did not take money. You could not get her to say ten words together. She lived up the bayou below Thibodaux. And everybody also knew what the old people said about the treating, that it would not cross water: that a traiteuse could do nothing for you across a bayou or a bay. For the Chênière, at the very bottom of everything, with fifty miles of bayou and marsh between, she would have to come herself.

She won't come, someone said. *It's the grinding. She's at Judge Arceneaux's with his wife. She promised him the season.*

They sent Ulysse Pitre anyway, who had married onto the Chênière from Thibodaux and whose people the judge knew, and with him the sacristan's boy, Ovide, who could write. They put together what they had to send with them, which was one sack of dried shrimp that had been on the Rigauds' high shelf, and a silver cup, and the church's altar cloth, which had been found in a tree.

II. The Judge's Road

Below Thibodaux · the middle of October

Judge Arceneaux had been judge of the district so long that nobody remembered he had been anything else. He was eighty. His wife was dying in the front bedroom of the house below Thibodaux, slowly, with the window open toward the bayou, and Tante Zélie had been sitting with her since the cane began to turn color, because he had asked, and because she had promised.

He received the two men from the Chênière on his gallery and heard them out. He took the shrimp and the cup and the altar cloth and laid them on the swing. Then he said, *You don't need me to ask her. You know how it's done. Ask her yourselves.*

So Ulysse and Ovide went around the side of the house to the back gallery, where she was sitting on a cane-bottomed chair shelling field peas into her apron, and they took their hats off, and Ulysse asked. He told her the count. He told her about the lights.

She was a small woman, past seventy, in a black dress and a sunbonnet. She went on shelling for a while. Then she put the peas in the pan.

Bon, she said.

That was the whole of it. Afterward people would ask Ulysse what else she had said, and he would say she had said *bon*, and they would not believe him.

The judge would not hear of her going down the bayou like a woman going to market. *Wait,* he said, *till I fix the road.* There was a road then along the upper bayou from Thibodaux down as far as Lockport, fifteen miles of it, dirt and shell and ruts. For three days the judge had men on it with shovels and drags, filling holes and pulling stumps, and his neighbors sent their men too, and shell came up from the landing by the wagonload and was spread white down the middle of it. Then the women came out. They brought flowers from every yard on the bayou, roses that had lived through the wind and four-o'clocks and goldenrod and the purple asters off the levee, and lantana, and when the flowers ran out, armfuls of the white fluff of the sea myrtle off the ditch banks, and they put it all down along the road so deep that in places, the old people say, it came to a man's knees. They hung bedsheets and tablecloths from the galleries. Every man who owned a flag of any kind put it out.

The judge walked beside her buggy the whole way. A boy held a black umbrella over her, and another held a second one, higher, over the first, because the judge said one was not enough. At every house along the road somebody came out to the gate with coffee or with a child to be touched or with a burn, and she stopped for every one, so that it took five days to go fifteen miles. Every night she slept in a different house, and every house fed her as if it were Easter.

At Lockport the judge had two oyster luggers lashed side by side, with a deck of boards across them and an awning of sailcloth on poles, and the awning wound around with flowers, and a chair from his own parlor set under it. She sat in the chair. Her grandson Placide, who poled her pirogue at home and went everywhere with her, sat on the boards at her feet. Ulysse and Ovide and a crew from the lower bayou took the sweeps.

Then the old judge did a thing people still talked about. He walked down the bank into Bayou Lafourche in his black suit and his good boots, in front of half of Lockport, and kept on walking until the water was at his neck, and put his two hands on the stern of the lugger and pushed it off.

I'll be right here, he said, with the water at his chin, *until you come back up.*

III. Down the Bayou

Lower Lafourche · three days

Below Lockport there was no road at all, only the bayou, with the houses along both banks facing it like people along a street, and the word had gone down ahead of her faster than the luggers could row.

The people of the lower bayou had decided among themselves that they would do twice what the judge had done. The houses on both banks were hung with whatever cloth was left after the storm. Men stood in the shallows holding up four umbrellas over the place where she would pass, and when she passed they waded out and walked alongside in the water. Where the storm had filled the channel with drift, cypress logs and roof timbers and the carcasses of cattle, the men of Leeville and the men from the Chênière who could still pull had gone out in the days before and dragged it all clear for three leagues, so that the bayou she came down was as clean as a swept floor. At every landing someone had a pot on, and they fed the crew twice what the judge had fed them, and they would not let Placide pay for so much as a cup of coffee.

Where the bayou opened into the marsh and the oaks of the Chênière ridge stood up grey against the sky, broken off, half of them, like teeth, the men of the Chênière came down into the water to meet her. They went in to their necks. They took hold of the lugger on both sides and walked it in through the shallows with their hands, and when it grounded they lifted her out of the parlor chair and carried her up the bank and set her down on the shell.

The moment her feet touched the ground, the sky over the Gulf turned the color of a slate and the rain came.

It was not a storm with wind in it. It was only rain, more rain than anyone had seen fall at one time, straight down, so heavy it hissed on the marsh. It filled every low place on the Chênière knee-deep and then thigh-deep and then to a man's waist, and then it found its way off, through the cuts and the bayous and the passes, all of it going out toward the Gulf. It ran all afternoon. When it stopped, the stink that had lain on the ridge for weeks was gone, and the lagoons were clean, and the marsh grass stood up washed. The rain had carried out to the Gulf what the trenches had not held. Nobody said that part out loud. They said the air was sweet. They stood in the wet and breathed it.

IV. Placide's Round

The Chênière · the first night, and seven days

That evening a relief steamer from New Orleans came into Caminada Bay with all her lamps lit. She carried flour and doctors and barrels of lime, and the light of her came across the water like a town arriving. Out in the marsh the little fires went out, most of them, one after another, the way lamps go out in a house when people go to bed.

Tante Zélie stood at the head of the path that went up the ridge, where the gate of the graveyard had been, and called Placide to her.

A traiteuse gives her prayers across, a woman to a man and a man to a woman, and they are never written down. She had been going to give them to Placide someday. She gave them to him there, in the dark, in the smell of wet ground and lime, with her mouth close to his ear, and nobody else heard them, and they are not written here. Then she took the white enamel bowl she carried in her bag, the one she used for everything, and dipped it full from the rain barrel at the Rigaud house, and put it in his two hands.

Go around, she said. *All the way. Three times.*

Placide went around the Chênière three times that night, in the three watches, from dark to the first grey, along the ridge and down through

the ruin of the houses and along the edge of the marsh and back, saying what she had given him, under his breath, over and over. Théodule Rigaud and some of the men went with him with lanterns. At the first word, they said, he dipped his hand in the bowl and threw the water up into the dark. It did not fall the way water falls. It hung for a moment in the lantern light, in drops like silver birdshot, and then came down on the people lying sick on pallets under the one roof and in the lee of the cisterns and in the boats pulled up on the shell, and wherever it touched them they got up.

They got up all over the Chênière, the old ones and the children, and came out, and followed him. By the third round there were more people behind Placide than had been left alive on the ridge, though nobody could ever say who the extra ones were.

Out in the marsh, the last of the lights went off toward the passes, fast, low, the way a flock goes. In the morning the chimney of the Naquin house, which had stood through the storm when the house around it went, was lying in the grass in one long piece, as if something had gone out through it in a hurry, and nobody had heard it fall.

The women had scrubbed the floor of the Rigaud house with lye and strewn it with bay leaves, and stretched a lugger's sail under the ceiling, and cut stars out of a piece of tin roof and hung them from the sail on threads, so that when the door opened they turned and caught the light. They set the judge's parlor chair under the stars. Tante Zélie sat in it, and the people came in and sat on the floor around her, and Placide came in with the ones who had followed him all night and sat down too.

She treated everyone who asked, for seven days, from that chair. She said very little. People who were there tried for the rest of their lives to tell what it had been like, those seven days in the room with the tin stars, and mostly they could not, and the ones who could not tell it were the ones you believed. At the end of the seven days there was no more flux on the Chênière, and the flour from the steamer had come ashore, and nobody saw a light in the marsh again that year.

Then she said she would go back up, because she had promised the judge the season.

V. The Manila Men

Barataria and the bayou · the end of October

THE PEOPLE OF THE CHÊNIÈRE TOOK HER BACK TO THE MOUTH of the bayou with twice the honor they had given her coming, which was everything they had, and more than they had.

But the Manila men were waiting.

They were the shrimp people of the bay, from the islands on the far side of the world, men who had come off Spanish ships two and three generations back and lived on platforms of cypress built out over the water, where they boiled and dried their shrimp in the sun and sent it to China. Some of them had Chinese partners and some had Cajun wives. Their platforms stood on pilings, and the storm had gone under the one in the bay where they lived and left most of it standing. They had heard about the parlor chair and the stars. They said to each other in their own language, and then in Spanish to the Cajuns, that the people of the land had honored her and they did not see why the people of the water should not.

So they came out from Barataria with every boat they had. They had painted the luggers. They had hung them with colored cloth and paper lanterns and the flags of three countries. They had brought, from somewhere up the freshwater bayous, so much water hyacinth in bloom that when they turned it loose ahead of her the brown bayou went purple for a mile, from bank to bank, and the boats pushed through flowers. And each crew asked her, in Spanish and in French and in their own tongue, to come into their boat.

It was the end of October, and the birds were coming down for the winter. That afternoon they came over in numbers that no one living had seen before or saw again: ducks and geese and white pelicans and long strings of ibis, flock over flock, one above another, so high that the top ones were only a shimmer, a roof of wings over the whole bayou all the way up into the sky, and under it the boats, and under the boats the flowers.

Tante Zélie sat in the judge's chair on the lashed luggers. That is certain. But every crew of every Manila boat swore afterward that she had sat with them, in their boat, in the stern, with her hands in her lap and her bonnet on, the whole way. Ulysse Pitre, who was at the sweep of the judge's lugger, said she never left the chair. The men in the Manila boats said she was in theirs. The men on the bank said they had seen her go by in every one. Nobody ever settled it, and after a while nobody tried.

The Manila men took her across the bay to the platform and gave her their best place out of the wind. They cooked all night: rice, and shrimp in tomatoes, and fish they had smoked, and a kind of sweet rice cake that nobody on the bayou had ever eaten, and coffee. She talked more that night than anyone had ever heard her talk. She talked in French, and they listened in Spanish and in Tagalog, and they understood her. In the morning they fed her again and took her back across to the bayou with a hundred boats behind.

At Lockport the judge was waiting on the bank, in the same black suit. He had been told she was coming, and the road was white with fresh shell again, and the flowers were down twice as deep as before, and he walked into the bayou to his neck once more to take the lugger in. He walked her home in five days.

VI. Toussaint

A sugarhouse below Thibodaux · the night of November 1

The grinding went day and night that time of year. In the sugarhouse on the plantation next to the judge's the kettles boiled from dark to dark, and the men who skimmed them and fed the furnaces and the women who brought them supper stayed up talking in the heat, and the smell of the cane juice cooking lay on the whole bayou like a blanket. Tante Zélie came over most nights to treat burns. On the night of the first of November, Toussaint, she came over late, from the graveyard, where the whole bayou had been all day whitewashing the tombs and setting out chrysanthemums, and sat down on a bench by the door to wait in case anyone burned himself.

They were talking about her. They had been talking about nothing else for a week. The road white with shell, fifteen miles. The judge to his neck in the bayou, twice, at eighty. The rain. The tin stars. The Manila boats, the hyacinths, the birds, a hundred boats and she in every one.

There was never anything like it on this bayou, said one of the kettle men. *Not for a bishop. Not for the governor.*

It's the gift she has, said a woman. *The power.*

Tante Zélie said, *What are you all talking about?*

They told her.

It wasn't any power of mine, she said. *Nor the judge's, nor the Manila men's either. I'll tell you what it was.*

They were so surprised to hear her say that many words in a row that the man at the last kettle let it boil over.

• • •

She had a son, she said. Aurélien. He was the one who could learn. When he was sixteen he told her and his father that he wanted to go to New Orleans and study, and his father had a friend among the Brothers who kept a school there, and they sent him to that friend. He learned faster than anybody the Brothers had ever had. Whatever went into him stayed, the way oil stays in a good jar. He learned English and Latin and his catechism and his figures, and in two years he knew everything the Brothers' school had to teach. But he wrote to her that he understood the beginning of it and the middle, and not the end, and when he asked his teacher who knew the end, the old Brother said he did not know it either, but that the Brothers who nursed the sick might.

So he went to them, and they told him they could not teach the end of it to anyone who stayed outside, and he put on the habit. They taught him first how to put it on. They taught him the rest. He wrote her once that he understood now.

That was 1878, the year of the yellow fever, when five thousand people died in New Orleans. The Brothers went into the houses where the fever was, and Aurélien went with them, and he was so good at it, so quiet and so quick, that people in the city began to ask for him by name, and the

newspapers printed it when he came through a street, and they said he had the touch. Then he took the fever himself and died of it in October, three weeks before the first cold, and the Brothers put him in a tomb by the gate of a cemetery on Esplanade, and the people he had nursed paid to have his name cut on it.

She did not know any of this. The letters had stopped coming in the summer, and the boats were tied up for the quarantine. At the end of October, when the first cold came and the boats began to run, she went to the city. She got there on the day of Toussaint, and the cemeteries were full of people whitewashing their tombs, and she went up to the biggest crowd she could find and asked whether anyone knew a young man named Aurélien Gautreaux, from Bayou Lafourche, who had come to the city to study with the Brothers.

Yes, they said. They knew him. He had studied with the Brothers, and become one of them, and gone into the fever houses, and died. That was his tomb, there by the gate.

She knelt down on the walk and hit the ground with her open hand until it hurt, and cried. Then she got up and went to the tomb. Nobody had tended it. The name on it was new, and the Brothers were still in the fever houses, and there had been no one to whitewash it. She pulled up the grass that had grown around its foot in the wet weeks, all of it, by the roots. She went to the walk and filled her apron with the white shell and brought it back and spread it around the tomb, two trips, three. She had a bottle of water from the bayou in her bag, from home, and she sprinkled it over the stone. She went out to the edge of the cemetery where there was a ditch and picked the wild asters and the goldenrod growing along it and laid them on the ledge. She hung her shawl from the little iron cross on the top, like a flag. And she opened her umbrella and wedged the handle down in the shell at the foot of the tomb so that it stood over his name. Then she walked to the boat in the rain without it.

I pulled the grass, she said, *and so the judge's men pulled the stumps out of fifteen miles of road, and the men of Leeville cleared the bayou. I spread the shell, and so they spread shell. I picked those few flowers off the ditch, and so they put flowers down to your knees and the Manila men covered the bayou with*

them. I sprinkled one bottle of water, and so the rain came on the Chênière. I put up my shawl and my umbrella, and so there were flags on every gallery and umbrellas over my head and boats with lanterns and birds all the way up to the top of the sky. That's all it was. One afternoon. A little grass and a little shell.

She was quiet a while. The kettles boiled.

He used to say a piece of an English poem to me, when he came home in the summer, she said. *The Brothers taught it to him. About the Acadians, our people, and the girl who looked for her young man all her life and found him at the end in a fever hospital. I don't have English. But I have that piece, because he said it so many times.*

And she said it, in his English, in the voice she used for the prayers:

> *Talk not of wasted affection, affection never was wasted;*
> *If it enrich not the heart of another, its waters, returning*
> *Back to their springs, like the rain, shall fill them full of refreshment;*
> *That which the fountain sends forth returns again to the fountain.*
>
> *— Longfellow, Evangeline II.i (1847)*

The kettle men did not have English either, most of them. But several of them said afterward that they had understood every word.

Then a boy at the strike pan put his wrist on the edge of the kettle and yelled, and she got up and went to him.

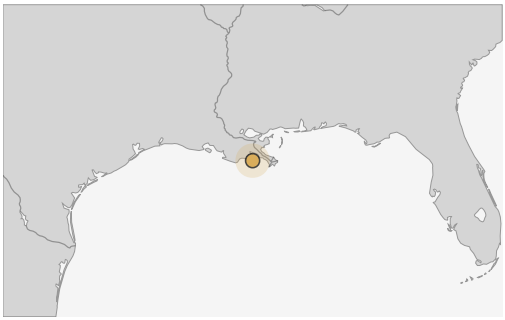
Background

The verse

> *If by leaving a small pleasure one sees a great pleasure, let a wise man leave the small pleasure, and look to the great.*
>
> Dhammapada 290, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the city of Vesālī suffers three dangers at once: famine, the non-human beings drawn by the unburied dead, and disease. Its people find no fault in their ruler and send two envoys to King Bimbisāra, who tells them to ask the Buddha themselves. The Buddha agrees. Bimbisāra smooths five leagues of road, strews it knee-deep with flowers, holds two white parasols over the Buddha, and wades into

the Ganges to his neck to launch his boat; the Licchavi princes on the far bank double every honor. When the Buddha sets foot in their country a great rain washes the corpses into the river. Ānanda walks the city walls through the three watches of the night reciting the Ratana Sutta and flinging water from the Buddha's bowl; the drops fall like silver on the sick, who rise, and the spirits break through the walls to flee. On the way back the Nāgas of the river cover it with lotuses and offer jeweled boats, the gods raise parasols to the highest heaven, and the Buddha makes a Buddha appear in every boat. Afterward, when the monks marvel, he says the honors came from one small deed: long ago, as the Brahmin Saṅkha, he traveled to find his son, who had gone away to study, become a solitary Buddha and died, and he cleared the grass from the son's shrine, spread sand, sprinkled water, scattered wildflowers, and raised his robe as a banner and his parasol over the mound. Read the full commentary story.



Bayou Lafourche and Chênière Caminada, Louisiana

Bayou Lafourche and the Chênière, 1878–1893

On the night of October 1–2, 1893, a small, intense hurricane came ashore at Chênière Caminada, a French-speaking fishing village of about 1,500 people west of Grand Isle that sent oysters, shrimp and crabs to New Orleans. The Weather Bureau had not known the storm existed. The surge put the village under six feet of water within minutes; 779 people died there, and only four of its 450 houses were left standing. The storm killed about 2,000 people in all and remains the deadliest in Louisiana's history. Survivors moved up Bayou Lafourche, "the longest Main Street in the world," to Golden Meadow, Leeville and Côte Blanche (now Cut Off), and some to Westwego; below Golden Meadow the bayou was the only road (Louisiana Folklife). Filipino sailors who had left Spanish ships had been settling the marshes since the eighteenth century and dried shrimp for export on platform villages like Manila Village in Barataria Bay. The sickness, the lights in the marsh and every person in this story are the story's own.

A traiteur or traiteuse treats with Catholic prayer and the laying on of hands, takes no payment, must be asked, and passes the secret prayers on to someone of the opposite sex; many say the treatment cannot cross water. The yellow fever epidemic of 1878 killed roughly 5,000 people in New Orleans; steamboats were tied up, and the fever lasted until the cold weather of late October. Longfellow's *Evangeline* (1847), the tale of an Acadian girl who searches all her life for her lost Gabriel and finds him dying in a fever hospital, did more than any other book to shape how Acadians and Cajuns were seen and saw themselves. On Toussaint, All Saints' Day, Louisiana families still clean and whitewash their tombs and bring chrysanthemums.

After the story of the Ascent of the Ganges from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 290). The original. Scripture from Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's *Evangeline: A Tale of Acadie* (1847). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.2

The Egg Chamber

> *But if ye bite and devour one another, take heed that ye be not consumed one of another.*
> *— Galatians 5:15*

This is how it gets told, on the river side of the island.

I. One Egg

Indian River, Florida · summer 1896

Josiah Yates fished mullet out of the Landing, on the river side of the barrier island below Melbourne Beach, where the land is so narrow that a man standing in his boat on the Indian River can hear the surf behind him. In June the loggerheads came up the ocean beach every night. Anybody who wanted eggs had only to walk the tide line at daybreak until he crossed a track as wide as a wagon's coming up out of the sea, follow it to the dune, and push a stick into the sand until it went in easy. One morning that June Josiah dug a lard bucket full, a hundred and some. His wife was at Titusville with her sister, so he carried the bucket next door to the Corbetts, and Mrs. Corbett boiled them for him.

A turtle egg is round and has a skin like wet kid leather. It dents under the thumb and stays dented, and however long it boils the white will not set. You tear a corner with your teeth, shake in salt and pepper, and squeeze. Josiah ate two dozen at the Corbett table. He gave one to the Corbett girl, Lottie, who was six and had been standing at his elbow the whole time.

After that one egg she would eat nothing else. She let grits go cold. She would not touch fish, and she held cornbread in her mouth until it fell out. She cried for turtle egg, and in August the turtles quit coming.

Her mother, at the end of her rope, went out one morning to the palmettos along the fence, where Mrs. Yates's dominicker hen had stolen a nest, and took one egg, still warm, and coddled it soft. The child ate it.

Mrs. Corbett meant to say something over the fence and did not. The next morning Lottie went to the palmettos herself, and every morning after that. She came to know when the hen had laid almost before the hen did. She took every egg of that clutch and the next, pricking the end with a thorn and sucking it where she stood.

The hen knew. Both families tell that part the same. She moved her nest three times. She would stand off under the guava tree with her feathers down flat and watch the child come. By November she had quit laying, and at Christmas she was dead under the house. Mrs. Yates, who had by then found out where a summer of her eggs had gone, said across the fence that the hen had died of it, and that she hoped the Corbetts would someday be robbed of a thing they were counting on.

The loggerhead that had laid the first hundred was by then somewhere off the Carolinas. Nobody at the Landing gave her a thought, then or for ninety-five years.

II. Turn About

The Landing · 1897–1986

The Corbetts tell the next part and the Yateses tell the part after it, and a person has to sit on both porches to get the whole.

The Corbetts say that the week the dominicker died, a gray kitten turned up under the Yates house that nobody had given them. It grew into a rangy cat with a flat head. The year Mrs. Corbett finally got a flock of her own, that cat came through the fence and cleaned out her best hen's nest three times, and the fourth time it took the hen. They say you could look in that cat's face and tell who she was.

The Yateses say that is foolishness. Then they say that around the year of the Armistice a Yates boy raised a doe fawn on a bottle, and she grew up and went wild only as far as the back fence, and dropped a fawn of her own in the wax myrtles. A panther swam the river from the Malabar

scrub, the last one anybody saw on the island, and killed the doe and the fawn in one night and was gone by morning. A panther does not swim a mile of salt water for no reason, the Yateses say, and the Corbetts always did have a way of getting what they wanted done by something else.

That is what gets told. What happened is plainer and runs the same direction. In 1926 somebody walked the revenue men to a still in the mangroves, and Dell Corbett, who was nineteen, did two years at Raiford. In 1943 a Corbett sat on the draft board, and both Yates boys went in the first call from the south beaches, and one came home. In 1958 a Yates sat on the school board, and a Corbett boy was put out of the tenth grade for a thing two other boys had also done. In 1974 a skiff burned at the dock with a Yates boy's whole first season of crab traps stacked in it.

It was the children every time. Nobody had ever sat down and decided that. Each side kept count only of its own.

III. The Bait Store Phone

The Landing · 1987–1991

Renee Yates and Jolene Corbett were the first of the two names to be friends since their great-great-grandmothers borrowed sugar. Jolene was four years older, and she had driven Renee to the high school in Melbourne every day for two years in her daddy's truck. People at the Landing took it for a sign that the thing had finally worn out.

Renee married Travis Hamm in 1986 and they set a single-wide on the Yates lot. The first boy came the next fall. Jolene was over the day they brought him home.

Where's Renee at?

Back bedroom, Travis's mother said. *They just got in with the baby.*

Boy or girl? Let me see him.

She held him a good while. She looked at him, and she looked at the space heater, and at Travis's cans on the counter, and at a place on Renee's arm. Then she kissed Renee and drove to her daddy's bait store. She picked up the pay phone by the ice machine, dialed the eight-hundred number that hung on a poster in every clinic in Florida, and told the state

abuse line a number of things about the Hamm trailer. Some of them were so. Travis did drink. A woman from HRS came out with a deputy on the nineteenth day and carried the boy to a foster home in Cocoa. A year later a judge ended it, and he went to people in another county under another name.

Jolene sat with Renee through all of that. She drove her to the hearings.

The second boy was born in 1989 at the hospital in Melbourne. The call was made before Renee was out of the bed, and with a file already open the state did not wait nineteen days.

It was the bait store that told on her. Renee's cousin Dwayne ran crab traps and bought his ice there, and twice he had seen Jolene at that phone with her back to the lot, on two days he later had cause to remember. In the winter of 1990 he said so. Renee did not go across the road. She did not say one word to Jolene, then or after. She had been told a story on the porch all her life about a hen and a cat, and she had taken it for a story.

That fall she was carrying again.

Travis, somebody on this island has got two of my babies took, and I know who. This one I'm having at Mama's.

Her mother lived at Fellsmere, twenty-five miles inland on the far side of the citrus. Travis had been eleven months without a drink. He said all right.

It happened that Jolene was gone. She cooked on a rock shrimp boat out of Port Canaveral, twelve and fourteen days to a trip, and that spring it was her turn and the boat stayed out. Renee went to her mother's in May and had the baby on the eleventh of June, a boy, and kept him.

Jolene came in off the boat on the twenty-eighth and drove to the Landing with the salt still on her.

Where's Renee?

Travis's mother stood in the trailer door. *Where you won't see her. Somebody keeps getting her babies took out of this house, and she's gone to her mama's to have this one.*

She can go where she likes, Jolene said. *She won't get shut of me.*

IV. Five Rules

State Road A1A · Sunday, June 30, 1991

Verna Platt was seventy-one. She had taught fifth grade for thirty-four years, with a Yates or a Corbett in the room most of them, and she had learned early not to seat them together. Four nights a week in June and July she led the turtle society's walk, by state permit, from the county dune crossover north of the inlet. She took twenty people at a time. Mostly they were retired couples from Indialantic and Satellite Beach, and that night there was also a family from Ohio. She gave them her five rules in the parking lot at dusk, as she had once given out the rules for the lunch line.

No flashlights. No flash on your cameras. No noise. Nobody touches her. And nobody takes one thing off this beach, not a shell.

The county had been making the oceanfront houses darken their windows in summer since the middle eighties. That year the government had begun buying up the dunes for a refuge, to be named for the turtle man at Gainesville. Roy Sumlin, who kept the lot for the county, stood at the head of the crossover on walk nights and saw that nobody followed the group up the beach. A college boy named Curtis scouted ahead with a red-lensed light. A little before nine he came back up the sand, held up one finger, and they all went down.

• • •

The baby had been dedicated that morning at the Baptist church in Fellsmere and named out loud before the congregation, Caleb. After the evening service Renee said they were going home. She said she was not going to hide at her mama's until he was grown. They came over the Wabasso causeway and up the beach road in the dark with the windows down. It was still eighty-two degrees. At the county crossover she told Travis to pull in.

Roy Sumlin was at the head of the steps, and he knew Travis from the fish house. *Turtle's up, north of here,* he said. *You all keep south and keep it down.*

She gave him the baby and walked into the surf in her church dress and went under. When she came out, Travis went in. She sat on the bottom step of the crossover with her hair dripping and nursed the baby, and for a few minutes nothing in the world was wrong.

Headlights swung across the lot above her and went out. She knew the sound of the door.

Travis! Travis, come quick! It's her!

She did not wait for him. She ran north up the beach with the baby. There was no moon yet and no lit window anywhere. Ahead of her on the sand was a dim red light, low down, with people kneeling around it, and she ran at that.

V. The Egg Chamber

The beach · the same night

The turtle had come out of the water at ten to nine and hauled herself to the foot of the dune. With her front flippers she had thrown out a pit as long as she was. Then she had dug the chamber with the hind ones alone, one cupped flipper and then the other, a foot and a half straight down into the damp sand, a hole she would never see. The twenty knelt in a half ring behind her, where she could not see them either. Verna lay on her stomach and held the red light down into it.

Then nothing happened. The turtle laid her chin on the sand and breathed. Ten minutes went by, and twenty. Verna had watched better than four hundred loggerheads on that beach, and she had never seen one finish her chamber and then lie over it empty. The people who were there say she was waiting.

Renee came into the red light at a dead run. She dropped on her knees and laid the baby down on the sand, between Verna Platt and the turtle's shoulder.

Take him. I'm giving him to you. Don't let her get him.

Nobody could say afterward who she had said it to. Verna thought it was to her. The woman from Ohio was sure it was to the turtle.

Back at the crossover Roy Sumlin saw a woman coming at him across the lot. Something in the way she came made him set his back against one rail and his arm across to the other.

Beach is closed, ma'am. There's a turtle up.

Verna looked at the baby on the sand. She looked at Renee Yates, whom she had taught long division. She listened down the beach to a voice she also knew.

Curtis. Go tell Roy I said let that woman by, and bring her up here. Walk her. Don't run.

Here she comes, Renee said, without turning her head.

Let her come, said Verna. *No noise.*

Jolene came up the beach behind the boy and stopped at the edge of the red light. She saw twenty strangers on their knees, and Renee in a wet dress, and the baby on his back with his fists up. She saw three hundred pounds of loggerhead with barnacles on her shell and water running out of her eyes. They cry the whole time they are on land. The turtle people will tell you it is only salt.

Jolene Corbett, Verna said. *Get down here. This side.*

She got down. The turtle began to lay.

The eggs came two and three at a time, white and wet and round as ping-pong balls, each landing soft on the ones before. Verna held the light so that both women could see down the hole. Every Yates and every Corbett had heard about a lard bucket of these since before they could sit up, and neither of the two had ever looked at one. The hind flippers curled and let go with each drop. The pile rose. Nobody spoke for twenty minutes. The baby slept, a yard from her face.

When the last had fallen Verna spoke, low, the way she said everything on the beach.

You both know whose eggs it was to begin with. She waited. *She never did come looking for anybody. It was the hen that took it up. You all have been the hen and the cat ever since, turn about, and every time it lands on a child. Coons will be in this nest by August or they won't. She is not coming back to see.*

> *But if ye bite and devour one another, take heed that ye be not consumed one of another.*
>
> *— Galatians 5:15*

The turtle filled the hole. She drew the sand in with her hind flippers and kneaded it down, and then she threw it back with the front ones in sheets, to hide the place. It came down on all of them. It fell in Jolene's hair and on Renee's wet dress and across the baby's blanket. He sneezed and did not cry. Nobody moved, because of the fourth rule. The turtle turned in her own length toward the sound of the water and went down the beach between the two women, a heave and a rest at a time. As the left front flipper went by, Verna put the red light on the metal tag and read it off to Curtis, who wrote it on the back of his hand. K 4417.

Jolene stayed on her knees with sand in her hair.

It was me that called, she said. *Both times. From Daddy's phone.*

I know it, Renee said.

I told them things that wasn't so.

Renee picked the baby up off the sand and shook out his blanket. Travis had come up behind the ring by then in his wet jeans and stood there with his hands open. A little before eleven the moon came up out of the ocean, three days past full. By its light they could all see the crawl she had left, from the dune down to the water, like the track of a tractor with one tire.

VI. The Tag

After

On Monday Jolene drove to the HRS office and asked for the file by the name on it. She sat four hours with a caseworker and went down it line by line, saying which of the things she had told them were so and which she had made. It took nine months and two hearings. The second boy came home in the spring of 1992, three years old, to people he did not know. The first had been adopted, and the judge would not open it. Renee carried that the rest of her life. So did Jolene.

The two of them were not friends again. They were something else, which neither family had a word for, and Caleb grew up in and out of both houses. Jolene took Verna Platt's five rules as though they had been said to her in particular. People at the Landing will tell you she kept them on the road and in the store the same as on the sand. She walked the dawn nest count for the society for twenty-two summers with a clipboard and a bundle of stakes.

The nest by the crossover hatched at the end of August on a night when nobody was watching. Jolene found it in the morning. There was a dent in the sand the size of a dinner plate, and from it the tracks of a hundred-odd hatchlings, each no wider than two fingers, fanned down to the water.

K 4417 came back in 1993 and again in 1996. Each time she nested inside half a mile of the crossover, four and five times in a season. Each time she covered what she had laid, threw sand over the place, and was in the water before it was light. Verna kept her card in the society's file box. It showed three seasons and thirteen nests, something like fifteen hundred eggs, and by the tracks the coons had been into four of the nests.

She never saw a one of them, Verna said, and put the card back behind the K.

Background

The verse

> *He who, by causing pain to others, wishes to obtain pleasure for himself, he, entangled in the bonds of hatred, will never be free from hatred.*
>
> Dhammapada 291, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a fisherman finds turtle eggs on a riverbank, has them cooked at a house, and gives one to a girl there, who afterward will eat nothing else. Her mother takes an egg from a hen's nest for her, and then the girl takes them herself. The hen conceives a grudge. The two are reborn as a cat and a hen, then as a leopardess and a doe, and in five hundred lives each devours the other's young. At last one is an ogress (*yakkhinī*) who, in the guise of a dear friend, twice eats a young wife's newborn. The third time the wife bears her child at her parents' house while the ogress

is away on her turn at drawing water. On the way home the couple bathe in the monastery pool; the wife sees the ogress coming, runs into the monastery, and lays the child at the Buddha's feet. A spirit at the gate holds the ogress back until the Buddha sends Ānanda to bring her in, saying, "Let her come; make no noise." He tells them that hatred is never ended by hatred, and the feud is over. Read the full commentary story. The second half is also told, with a different beginning, as the story of the ogress Kāḷī, which this series retells in Dinner on the Ground. On yakkhas and yakkhinīs.

South Brevard beaches, Florida

The south Brevard beaches, 1991

The twenty miles of barrier island between Melbourne Beach and Wabasso are the most important nesting ground of the loggerhead sea turtle in the Western Hemisphere, and the Archie Carr National Wildlife Refuge was established there in 1991, named for the University of Florida zoologist who had died four years earlier. A female comes ashore several times in a season, about two weeks apart, digs an egg chamber with her hind flippers, lays around a hundred eggs, covers them, and leaves; she then stays away for two or three years. Raccoons are the chief robbers of nests on that coast. The tears are real: glands behind the eyes shed the salt she takes in with seawater. Beginning with Brevard County in the mid-1980s, Florida's coastal governments required beachfront lights to be shaded or put out during nesting season, since lights turn hatchlings away from the sea. Guided night walks run under state permit in June and July, about twenty people at a time, with red lights only.

Settlers along the Indian River dug turtle eggs every summer; a state law of 1907 protected nesting turtles on the beach, and later law protected the eggs. The railroad reached Melbourne in 1893. HRS was Florida's Department of Health and Rehabilitative Services, which ran the state's child-abuse hotline and its foster care until it was broken up in the late 1990s. The Landing, the Yates and Corbett families, Verna Platt and turtle K 4417 are invented.

After the story of the woman who ate chicken eggs from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 291). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

21.3

Fifty-One Percent

> *Martha, Martha, thou art careful and troubled about many things: But one thing is needful.*
> *— Luke 10:41–42*

Así lo oí yo, behind the third field at Boca Chica.

I. Paint

The Phillies academy, Boca Chica, Dominican Republic · June 2018

The academy sat on forty-five acres of flat ground a few kilometers in from the sea, behind a wall with the two clubs' names on the gate, the Phillies on one side of the compound and the Twins on the other. Each club had three fields, covered cages, a weight room, a video room, three classrooms with whiteboards, and a dormitory where seventy-some boys slept two and three to a room under air conditioning that most of them had never had at home. The youngest were sixteen. They had signed the summer before, on the second of July, when the international signing period opened, and some of them had received more money on that one day than their fathers had earned in their lives, and most of it was already gone, to a house for the mother, a motorbike for the brother, a debt in the colmado, and the cut that went to the buscón who had trained them since they were twelve and fed them and owned a piece of them still.

It began with Yandel Ozuna's cleats.

Yandel was a shortstop from Baní, seventeen, with hands so quiet the coaches stopped talking when he took ground balls. He came back from a Sunday at home with a pair of game spikes that a man in Bayona had painted for him with leather paint out of little jars. On the outside heel of

the left one there was a Dominican flag. On the right, a palm tree against a sunset, and his mother's name, *Altagracia*, in gold script along the side, and on both toes the club's script P, outlined in glitter. It had cost him two thousand pesos and taken the man a week.

By the end of June there were eleven pairs. Cristian Mejía, a center fielder from Hato Mayor, had flames. Wilmer from Barquisimeto, one of the four Venezuelans, had the yellow, blue and red of his own flag and eight white stars, and he had painted them himself, at night, with a brush he bought in Boca Chica, and the whole wing smelled of acetone. Ángel Luis had a pair of slides woven out of yarey palm from a stall on the highway, the way they make the hats, which he wore to breakfast and to the classroom and in the shower until they came apart. Somebody had Crocs so studded with charms you could not see the plastic: little Dominican flags, a gold crown, a Jordan, a slice of pizza, a baseball, Bad Bunny's face. Somebody had chancletas with plastic hibiscus glued across the straps. Somebody's cousin in Santo Domingo sold a pair of white turf shoes with green artificial grass glued on the sides like a lawn, and they passed from foot to foot down the hall for a week as a joke, and then nobody was joking about them anymore, and three boys wanted their own.

At night it was Fortnite. They had two consoles in the lounge and phones in every bunk, and they played until two and three in the morning, and what they spent their money on there was skins. A skin did nothing. A boy dressed as a dinosaur ran no faster and shot no straighter than a boy dressed as a soldier. They bought them anyway, with real pesos turned into V-Bucks, and they bought the little dances, and when one of them dropped into the game in something new the others would scream down the hall.

They were late to the early work. They sat in the back of the English class with their heads down on the desks. The video room, where the coaches could show a boy his own swing frame by frame until he saw what they saw, was empty in the afternoons. They did the drills, because the coaches were standing there, but their eyes were on each other's feet.

II. The Older Ones

The dormitory · early July

Not everyone thought it was funny. Rainier Coss was a catcher from Maracay, nineteen, in his third summer at the academy, which meant he was running out of summers, and he had a pair of black spikes with the club logo worn off the toes from dragging them in the dirt. Junior Peralta was a pitcher from Monte Plata who had come back from elbow surgery and spent a year doing nothing but bands and towel drills in front of a mirror, and the scar on the inside of his arm was still pink.

They did not say anything at first. Then one night in the lounge somebody held up Rainier's cleats by the laces and asked who had died, and everybody laughed, and Rainier took them back and went out and sat on the steps in the dark.

In the morning he and Junior went to Don Teo.

III. The Rule

The agility field · the next morning, before six

Teodoro Peguero was fifty-eight and had been the academy's field coordinator for nine years. He was a small, dark man with a gray mustache and a belly, and he walked with his feet a little turned out, the way infielders do who have spent their lives getting ready to go either way. He did not shout. He did not use the whistle around his neck. In nine years most of the boys had heard him say perhaps a hundred words, and the ones who later reached Allentown or Philadelphia could repeat most of them.

He had been born on a sugar batey outside San Pedro de Macorís, where the cane cutters lived in barracks between the fields and the company owned the water. He had learned to play barefoot, on a lot of packed red dirt beside the rail line where the cane carts ran, with a glove cut and folded out of a milk carton and a ball made of a sock wound with tape. He did not own a pair of shoes until the club that signed him in 1977

gave him a pair of spikes, and he said later that he had not liked them, because he could no longer feel where he was.

He had played eleven years in the minor leagues, in towns whose names he could still recite in order. In September of 1980, when he was twenty, he was called up to the Phillies for nineteen days. He played in nine games at Veterans Stadium, on the green carpet laid over concrete, where for the first time in his life he could not feel the ground at all, and had two hits, one of them a ground ball through the right side that he said he still felt in his hands. He was sent down before the playoffs. He watched the last game of the World Series on a television in a colmado in San Pedro with half the batey crowded in the door, and before the last out the police came out of the tunnels and stood all around the edge of the field, men on horses and men holding dogs, a ring of them, to keep the crowd off the carpet when it was over, and when the last man struck out and sixty-five thousand people stood up screaming behind the horses, he was the only man in San Pedro who had stood on that carpet, and he did not say so.

Now he sent word that the boys from the painted wing were to be on the agility field at a quarter to six, in whatever they had on their feet.

They came. It was barely light. The ground was wet and the air smelled of cut grass and the sea. They stood in a ragged line in the flames and the flags and the palm trees and the glitter, and Ángel Luis in what was left of his yarey slides, and Don Teo walked down the line slowly, looking at their feet and not at their faces, the way you look at horses.

Then he took a folded paper out of his back pocket. It was a page printed off the internet, and he read it to them in Spanish and then in English, because English was one of the things they were here for.

At least 51% of the exterior of each Player's shoes must be the Club's designated primary shoe color.

He folded it again.

That's the big leagues, he said. *In May they warned a man in Chicago who has two rings, about black shoes. Black. You think they won't send one to you?*

Nobody answered.

So here is the rule here. On the field, plain spikes, the club's color. One pair of plain chancletas for the dormitory. The rest goes in a box. You can have it back when you leave, whichever way you leave.

Yandel said, very quietly, *Don Teo, it's only paint.*

Don Teo looked at him for a while.

You came here for one thing, he said. *And you are doing another.*

That was all of the rebuke. He did not raise his voice and he did not say anything about the English class or the empty video room or the games at two in the morning, and every one of them understood that he knew all of it. He took a small black Bible from the pocket of his windbreaker, the old Reina-Valera with the cover gone soft, and turned to a place he did not need to look for.

> *Marta, Marta, cuidadosa estás, y con las muchas cosas estás turbada: Empero una cosa es necesaria.*
>
> *Martha, Martha, thou art careful and troubled about many things: But one thing is needful.*
>
> *— Lucas 10:41–42 (Reina-Valera 1909); Luke 10:41–42 (KJV)*

One, he said, and held up a finger, the way the coaches hold up a finger for one out.

IV. Barefoot

The agility field · sunrise

THEN HE SAT DOWN ON THE WET GRASS AND UNLACED HIS OWN shoes, a pair of old gray running shoes with the heels broken down, and took off his socks and stuffed them in the shoes, and stood up barefoot. His feet were wide and pale on the bottom and the toes were crooked from fifty years of being stepped on.

Take them off.

They looked at each other. Then they sat down in a row in the grass and took them off, the flags and the flames and the palm tree and Altagracia in gold, and the Crocs with the charms, and set them side by

side behind them, and stood up. The grass was cold. Someone laughed, once, and stopped.

Don Teo walked them out to the skin of the infield, where the dirt had been dragged smooth the evening before and not yet touched. He set himself at shortstop, knees bent, weight on the balls of his feet.

Right foot. Left foot. Feel the ground take you. Now the ball is here. He showed them, without a ball. A small step with the right foot to the side, the left coming through, the glove hand down and out in front, the throwing hand closing over it, the right foot crossing behind to set, and the throw, which went nowhere, which went to first base in the air. Then again, very slowly. Then again. *Where is your right foot? Don't look. Where is it?*

They did it with him. At first they did it badly, looking down, bumping into each other, a line of teenage boys in gym shorts doing a slow dance in the dirt. He made them do it slower. He made them do it with their eyes closed. He made them tell him, every time, without looking, where the right foot was and where the left foot was and which way the weight was going. *The feet know before you do,* he said. *That is the only thing I know. If you know where your feet are, always, you will not need anybody to paint anything on them.*

The sun came up over the wall behind the third field and the dirt began to warm under them. They did it fifty times. They did it a hundred. No one had told them to count and they counted anyway, under their breath. Somewhere past a hundred the counting stopped. So did the bumping into each other. The boys who were there say that something happened on that infield they have never been able to describe to anyone who was not.

Yandel said once, years later, that it was like the first time he had ever been on a field at all. That he could feel the dirt through the soles of his feet, every pebble, and the boy on his left breathing, and the boy on his right, and the place where the ball would be before it was there, and that for a while there was nothing he wanted. Not the paint. Not the skins. Not even, for that morning, the big leagues. Only the next step, and he was already taking it.

Don Teo stopped them when the grounds crew came out with the drag. He stood with his hands on his knees, breathing hard, an old man with dirt to his ankles. Then he said the other verse, without taking the Bible out, and they listened with their feet in the warm dirt.

> *Antes hiero mi cuerpo, y lo pongo en servidumbre; no sea que, habiendo predicado á otros, yo mismo venga á ser reprobado.*
>
> *But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.*
>
> *— 1 Corintios 9:27 (Reina-Valera 1909); 1 Corinthians 9:27 (KJV)*

• • •

The painted spikes went into a cardboard box that had held batting gloves, and the box went on a shelf in the equipment room under the bucket of rosin bags, and over the years more pairs went in on top of them. Nobody took theirs back. When Yandel left for Clearwater the next spring he forgot to ask for his, and when he remembered he did not write.

That evening the grounds crew came out to drag the infield, as they did every evening, and when they got to the shortstop's side they stopped and called each other over. The dirt there had been dragged that afternoon after the game, and swept, and watered down. But in the wet skin of it, in a long curved line from the hole toward second base, there were footprints, bare, all the same size, right foot, left foot, the right crossing behind, set and throw, over and over, as if one person had made them a hundred times and stepped every time exactly where he had stepped before.

They raked them out. In the morning they were there again.

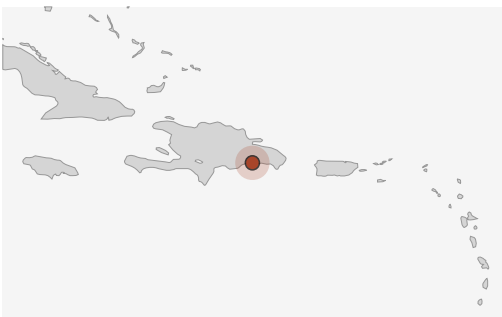
Background

The verses

> *What ought to be done is neglected, what ought not to be done is done; the desires of unruly, thoughtless people are always increasing.*
>
> Dhammapada 292, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *But they whose whole watchfulness is always directed to their body, who do not follow what ought not to be done, and who steadfastly do what ought to be done, the desires of such watchful and wise people will come to an end.*
>
> Dhammapada 293, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest in the collection. The monks of Bhaddiya took to ornamenting their footwear, making or having made sandals of grass, of thatch, of reeds, of palm leaves, of bulrush and of wool, and neglected their instruction, their questions and their training in conduct, meditation and wisdom. Other monks were offended and told the Buddha, who laid down rules about sandals and rebuked them: "You came here for one purpose, but have devoted yourselves to another." He spoke the two verses, the second about mindfulness of the body, and the monks of Bhaddiya reached the end of the path as he finished. The story quotes the Vinaya's chapter on footwear (Mahāvagga 5). Read the full commentary story.



Boca Chica, Dominican Republic

Boca Chica, 2018, and Veterans Stadium, 1980

Major League clubs sign Latin American teenagers as young as sixteen and house them at academies in the Dominican Republic, where they train, take English and other classes, and play in the Dominican Summer League. The Twins and Phillies opened a shared $18 million academy at Boca Chica in January 2017, with three fields, batting cages, classrooms and dormitory space for each club (MLB.com). Many players have come from San Pedro de Macorís and the sugar bateyes around it. Until

the end of 2018, Major League uniform rules required that at least 51 percent of each shoe's exterior be the club's designated color; after a spring of warnings to players over their cleats, the league and the players' union loosened the rule for 2019 (MLB.com). That same year the free-to-play Fortnite Battle Royale, which makes its money selling purely cosmetic outfits and dances, was at the height of its first craze.

The Phillies won the first World Series in their history in 1980, beating the Kansas City Royals in six games (1980 World Series). Game 6 was played on October 21 before 65,838 people at Veterans Stadium, whose field was AstroTurf, and in the top of the ninth the city put police on the field, some on horses and some with dogs, to keep the crowd from storming it at the end.

After the story of the monks of Bhaddiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 292–293). The original. Scripture from the Reina-Valera 1909 and the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.4

Ash Glaze

> *Over a mass of reddish flesh there sits a true man who has no title.*
> *— Rinzai, in D. T. Suzuki, Essays in Zen Buddhism (1927)*

Nyoze gamon, at the head of Laurel Branch.

I. The Kiln

Laurel Branch, Yancey County, North Carolina · October 2004

Morio Hata had come to the mountains in the summer of 1972 to teach a three-week workshop at the craft school over at Penland, and at the end of the three weeks he did not go back to Kyoto. He was the third son of a kiln family in Shigaraki, which meant there was no kiln for him at home, and he had been a Soto priest since he was nineteen, which meant he could sit anywhere. In 1975 he bought forty acres at the head of Laurel Branch from a widow named Edney who was glad to be done with them: a frame house, a springhouse, a quarter-acre burley allotment he rented back to her nephew, and a tobacco barn on the slope that he swept out and put a floor in and made into a zendo. The cracks between the boards were left as they were. In winter you sat in your coat and the wind came through in stripes.

In 1983, with the help of eleven students and a mason from Spruce Pine, he dug a kiln into the hill behind the barn. It was twenty-six feet long and shaped like a loaf of bread, with a firebox at the low end and a chimney at the high one, and it lay along the slope the way a dog lies on a step. By the autumn of 2004 it had been fired forty-one times. People came from all over the country to put pots in it.

That October four came up from Atlanta, from a sitting group that met on Tuesday nights in the parlor of a Methodist church in Decatur. Marcy Feld was a public defender. Daniel Oh was writing a dissertation at Emory on Japanese temple economies. Tom Ricketts had flown for Delta for thirty-one years and had retired in July. Celeste Ware was a hospice nurse who had arranged her shifts so she could have the week. They drove up on a Thursday with their pots wrapped in towels in the back of Tom's Suburban, and on Friday they met Ben.

Ben Gatti was four feet and two inches tall. He had come to Laurel Branch in 1990, at thirty, from Barre, Vermont, where his mother's people had been stonecutters, and he had stayed. There was a lily in Hope Cemetery in Barre, cut into the granite by a man no taller than Ben, that his mother had taken him to see when he was nine, and he still had the rubbing they made of it. He did the books and the garden and the morning chant. The anagama door was thirty inches wide and the kiln was not much higher than that inside, and a full-sized man loading the back of it had to lie on his side on the sand floor and pass the pots ahead of his face. Ben could kneel in there. For fourteen years he had loaded the back.

They watched him go in on Friday morning with a headlamp and a bucket of wadding, the little wads of kaolin and alumina that keep a pot from welding itself to the shelf, and they listened to him working his way up the slope in the dark, and then they heard him start to sing. He had a light, clear voice, a tenor that seemed to have nothing pushing it from behind. It came out of the door and up through the chimney at the same time. It was the Heart Sutra in Japanese, the way he led it every morning in the barn, and then it was something in Italian, and then it was a Patsy Cline song, all in the same voice and with no break between.

Who is that? said Celeste.

Hata Sensei was sitting on an upturned bucket beside the firebox, sorting cones.

That's Ben, he said.

The loading took two days. The front of the kiln was what everybody wanted. Near the firebox the flame was hottest and the ash fell thickest, and a pot that sat there for six days came out with a green glaze running

down its shoulder like water down a rock, or with its whole face crusted and pitted where the coals had buried it. In the back, at the top of the slope, a pot might come out with nothing on it but a blush of orange where the flame had touched it going by. Marcy had brought a tall jar she had thrown in a class in Little Five Points and had worked on for a month, and she wanted it near the front, and so did everybody. There was a certain amount of talk about it, polite and Southern and not quite joking. Ben set the four of them a shelf in the second row and took his own pots, which were small, cups and little lidded jars, up into the back with him.

Doesn't he want them up front? said Tom.

Ask him, said Hata Sensei. Nobody did.

On Saturday afternoon Hata Sensei bricked up the door, leaving the firebox mouth and a row of spy holes, and set the cone packs where he could see them through the holes, and lit a small fire of kindling in the mouth of the kiln, and sat down on his bucket beside it. He was seventy-five. He would sit there, on and off, for six days.

II. Father and Mother

The firebox · Wednesday afternoon

By the fifth day the kiln had a voice of its own. It drew air in at the firebox with a long low sound like somebody breathing through a cold, and each time you stoked it, a split of pine laid in through the mouth, it went quiet, and black smoke rolled out the top of the chimney, and then the smoke cleared and the roar came back a little higher. The front cones had gone over in the night. The spy holes were too bright to look into without welding glasses, and when you did look, the pots inside had lost their shapes and become places where the light was a little thicker.

The four from Atlanta had their shift from noon to six. They stoked when Hata Sensei raised a finger. In between they sat with him on a row of buckets and cinder blocks out of the heat and ate the rice balls Ben brought up from the house at two. The pine came from a sawmill on the

Cane River, slab wood with the bark still on it, and their hands were black with pitch to the wrist. Across the branch the Edney nephew's barn was hung to the rafters with burley, turned the color of saddle leather, the last crop on the allotment. Congress had passed the buyout, and everybody on the creek was waiting for the President to sign it. On the radio hung on a nail in the kiln shed, when there was no news about it, there was baseball.

At about half past two Ben came up the path from the barn with an armload of slab across his chest that reached nearly to his chin. He was singing under his breath. He nodded to them and went by to the woodpile on the far side of the shed and began to stack.

Hata Sensei watched him go by. Then he looked at the four of them on their buckets.

Look, he said. *That one killed his mother and his father. And look how he goes. Nothing on him.*

Nobody said anything. The kiln breathed in. Marcy Feld had sat beside three clients charged with killing a parent in nine years of practice, and she found she had turned around on her bucket to look at the little man stacking pine, and was looking at his hands. Daniel Oh was thinking it must be a koan and was ashamed that he did not know which one. Tom thought the old man's English had slipped, as it sometimes did when he was tired, and was waiting for him to correct it. Celeste had been with a great many people while they died and had heard them say all kinds of things at the end about their mothers and fathers. They looked at each other, and each of them saw that the others had heard the same thing, and that did not help.

Sensei, Tom said finally. *What do you mean?*

Hata Sensei raised a finger. Tom got up and laid a split into the firebox mouth, and the roar dropped, and the smoke went up black and then thinned, and Tom sat down again.

Mother is wanting, said Hata Sensei. *Everything is born from her. This pot, that pot. I want the front. Father is I. I am the one who made it. My jar. He killed both of them.*

He turned a cone over in his fingers.

Then two kings. One king says, You will go on forever. Your name, your pots, everything. The other king says, When you die, nothing. Nothing matters. Both kings, he killed. And the kingdom and all the people in it. Eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, mind. All the people who work for them, and all the people they bring in, all day. He killed the whole country.

And now he goes like that.

They looked over at Ben, who was laying slab crosswise on the stack so it would dry, two this way and two that way, and singing.

Hata Sensei said that in China there had been a teacher named Rinzai who was very rough with his students, and who once got up in front of them and said a thing that nobody in the hall could answer. He said it in English, the way he had first read it, in a book of Suzuki's he had bought secondhand in Kyoto as a student:

> *Over a mass of reddish flesh there sits a true man who has no title; he is all the time coming in and out from your sense-organs. If you have not yet testified to the fact, Look! Look!*
>
> *— Rinzai, in D. T. Suzuki, Essays in Zen Buddhism (1927)*

No title, he said. *No king.*

Then he raised a finger and Celeste got up to stoke, and that was all he said about it.

They sat there until six. When the next shift came up from the house and they went down, nobody on the path said anything about the jar. It was in the second row. It was going to come out the way it came out. Marcy said later, in Decatur, that it was as if somebody had been standing on her foot for her whole life and had just stepped off it, and she had not known until then that there was a foot. She did not quit the public defender's office. She kept the jar, when it came out, on the floor of her office beside the chair where her clients sat, and it was the first thing they looked at and the last.

III. The Painter

The firebox · Thursday, after midnight

The Ray boys from the sawmill came up the branch in their father's truck on the last night with a final load of slab. Cody was nineteen and Dwayne was seventeen, and their father had put in for the buyout on his quota and was talking about selling the mill too and going to work at the hospital in Spruce Pine, and Cody had a cousin in Charlotte who said he could get him on with a drywall crew, and nobody in the family could decide anything. They unloaded the slab, and then because the kiln was the only light on Laurel Branch at that hour and there was a roar coming out of it like a jet, they stayed.

Hata Sensei was on his bucket. He had been up most of two nights. Flame was coming out of the top of the chimney now, three feet of it, the color of the inside of a peach, and in its light the boys could see the burley hanging in the Edney barn across the branch, and the moths.

Ben came out of the dark with the side-stoking rods and went along the kiln wall, pulling a brick from each port, feeding a handful of thin pine in and putting the brick back. The heat off the ports made the air above him swim. He did it the way he did everything, without hurry and without stopping.

Hata Sensei looked at him, and then at the two Ray boys.

That one killed his mother and his father, he said. *Two kings. And a tiger, five. And he goes like that.*

Dwayne laughed, because he thought it was a joke, and then stopped, because the old man was not laughing. Cody, who was the one who could not decide about Charlotte, said, *We don't have tigers up here.*

What do you have?

Painters. Used to. My granddaddy said he heard one scream on the Bald Mountains.

Painter, then, said Hata Sensei. He told them about the mother and the father and the two kings, the way he had told it on Wednesday, and then about the painter. *There are five things that sit beside the path and wait for you,* he said. *Wanting the thing. Hating the thing. Sleepy. Worried. And the*

fifth one is the painter. The fifth one is doubt. Should I go, should I stay. Is this the right one, is that one. It never jumps. It waits beside the path and you never go by.

He killed that one too, he said, and nodded at Ben, who had come to the end of the ports and was standing at the high end of the kiln in the heat of the chimney with the rods in his hand, looking up at the flame.

Cody Ray did not say anything then. In March he went to Charlotte, and he came home most weekends, and in 2009 he came home for good and put up drywall from Burnsville to Bakersville, and he never said that one choice had been better than the other. He told the story about the painter to his own boys, but he told it as a story about a painter.

They clammed the kiln up at four in the morning on Friday. Ben and the Ray boys bricked the firebox mouth and the ports and daubed every seam with wet clay, and the roar stopped as if a door had shut on it somewhere, and the kiln ticked and sighed in the dark. Then for six days it cooled, and nobody could do anything about anything in it.

IV. The Back

Laurel Branch · the next Thursday

On the morning they unbricked the door it was cold enough that the heat coming out of the kiln stood up in a column in the air, and the Edney nephew came across the branch to watch, and so did the Rays. By then the President had signed the buyout. The Red Sox had won the World Series the night before for the first time since 1918, and Ben, who had been raised in Barre on Red Sox radio, had gone to bed at nine as usual and found out at breakfast, and said, *Well, good.*

The front of the kiln came out first. Some of it was very fine. A bottle near the firebox came out with a green ash glaze running in long beads down one side and a black glossy shoulder where the coals had lain, and the woman from Asheville who had made it held it in both hands and could not say anything. Some of it was ruined. A bowl had slumped. Two pots had fallen against each other and fused into one thing, which Hata Sensei looked at a long time and then set aside for himself.

Marcy's jar came out of the second row with a gray-green crust on its shoulder like lichen on a fencepost and a long scar on its foot where the wad had torn away, and she looked at it, and then she put it down on the board with the others and went back to the door to take the next thing Ben handed out.

Ben went into the back last, on his knees, with the headlamp. He handed his cups out one at a time. They were the color of toast, mostly, with an orange blush on the side where the flame had gone by them on its way up the chimney. They had almost no ash on them. On one there was a single green bead, the size of a lentil, that had fallen from somewhere above and melted where it landed.

Hata Sensei took that one. Ben came out of the kiln backward and sat on the sand at the door to take off his kneepads.

There was green tea in a thermos. Hata Sensei poured it into the cup with the green bead and drank it standing in the cold, with the burley hanging behind him in the barn across the branch, and then he poured it again and handed it to Ben, and Ben turned the cup in his hands until the green bead was under his lip, and drank.

Background

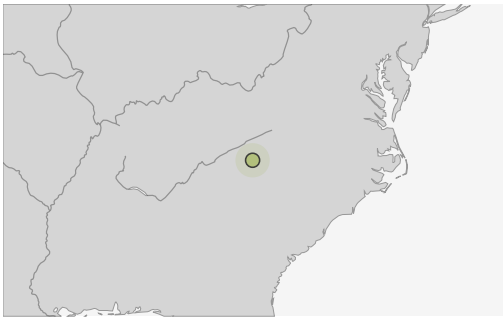
The verses

> *A true Brahmana goes scatheless, though he have killed father and mother, and two valiant kings, though he has destroyed a kingdom with all its subjects.*
>
> Dhammapada 294, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *A true Brahmana goes scatheless, though he have killed father and mother, and two holy kings, and an eminent man besides.*
>
> Dhammapada 295, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is a few lines long. The Buddha is sitting in his day-quarters at Jetavana with some visiting monks when the elder Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya, "Bhaddiya the Dwarf," walks past. The Buddha says that there goes a monk who has killed his mother and father and goes on free of pain. The visitors look at one another in doubt and ask what he means, and he answers with the verse. The commentary reads it as a riddle: mother and father are craving and conceit, the two kings are the views that

the self lasts forever and that it is annihilated at death, and the kingdom with its followers is the passion for the twelve spheres of sense. The second verse, told the same way, puts a tiger fifth, which the commentary takes as the five hindrances, the fifth of them doubt. The visitors become arahats. Elsewhere the canon names Lakuṇṭaka, small and mocked for it, as foremost among monks with a sweet voice. Read the full commentary story, or about Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya and the five hindrances. Hata Sensei's lines are a saying of the Chinese master Linji (Rinzai in Japanese), from the first series of D. T. Suzuki's *Essays in Zen Buddhism*.



Laurel Branch (fictional), Yancey County, North Carolina

The Toe River Valley, 2004

In 1923 Lucy Morgan, a teacher at the Appalachian School in the Mitchell County village of Penland, began teaching weaving to local women, and by 1929 the work had become the Penland School of Handicrafts, with classes in pottery among the first. After 1962 its second director, Bill Brown, turned it toward working artists with a resident program and longer courses, and studio potters, glassblowers and other craftspeople settled in the surrounding counties of Mitchell and Yancey. Many of the potters fire with wood. An anagama is a single sloping tunnel with the firebox at its low end and the chimney at its high one; it is stoked around the clock for days, and the wood ash that settles on the pots melts into glaze, heaviest near the fire and lightest at the back. Its line runs to medieval Japan, to kiln towns such as Shigaraki.

The same mountain counties grew burley tobacco on thousands of small allotments, cut whole in the field and air-cured for one to two months in open barns. Federal quotas had governed the crop since 1938. On October 22, 2004, the Fair and Equitable Tobacco Reform Act became law, ending the quotas and paying their holders a buyout; about $4 billion of it went to North Carolina, and most small burley growers in the mountains took it and quit. Five days later the Boston Red Sox finished a four-game sweep of St. Louis to win the 2004 World Series, their first championship since 1918.

After the story of the elder Lakuṇṭaka Bhaddiya from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 294–295). The original. The words of Rinzai from D. T. Suzuki, *Essays in Zen Buddhism, First Series* (1927). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.5

The Brass Tray

> *I laid me down and slept, and rose up again; for the Lord sustained me.*
> *— Psalm 3:5*

Heek smi'it, on the Little Muddy.

I. The Can on the Post

Williams County, North Dakota · summer 1907

There were eleven Syrian claims on the flats north of the Little Muddy that summer, nine sod houses and two of lumber, strung out a half mile apart along the section lines like beads somebody had dropped and not picked up. The men had come out on the Great Northern as peddlers, with their cases on their backs, and had seen all that land lying open and free for anybody who would file on it and live on it five years. They wrote home to the villages above Zahleh, and the cousins came. By 1907 there were wives on the flats, and babies born in sod houses, and a cemetery with two Syrian graves in it at the corner of the Saba claim, marked with crosses cut from packing-case boards.

The boys of the colony played ball against the side of the Saba barn. There were not enough of them to make up nine, so they played a game of their own. Somebody set a tomato can on a fence post forty paces off, and you threw at it, and if you knocked it off you threw again, and the one who knocked it off most times before dark was the winner. The ball had been wound by Mikhail Saba's mother out of an old wool sock around a rubber ball, sewn over with harness thread, and it went where you sent it.

Mikhail Saba won. He won nearly every evening. He was eleven, small for it, with his father's long hands, and before every throw he crossed himself, three fingers together, right shoulder before left the way the Orthodox do, and as the ball left his hand he said, not loudly, *Ya Rabb, irham.* Lord, have mercy. His father Hanna was the chanter for the colony, the one who led the prayers on Sundays when there was no priest, which was nearly every Sunday, because the nearest priest was at Rugby, nearly two hundred miles east on the Great Northern. In the Saba house they said *Ya Rabb, irham* the way other people breathed. Mikhail said it throwing a ball.

Faris Malouf lost. He was eleven too, and bigger, and he threw harder than anybody, and he shouted *Abu Zayd!* every time he threw, because that was what his father did. Assaad Malouf knew the whole story of Abu Zayd al-Hilali, the black hero of the Bani Hilal who rode out of Arabia and took cities with his sword, and he told it the way men told it in the coffeehouses at home, in the long rhymed lines, night after night, so that Faris had grown up with Abu Zayd sitting at the supper table like an uncle. Assaad did not cross himself. He said priests ate the first lamb and the last lamb and blessed the bones for the poor. He wore a blue glass bead on a string under his shirt against the eye of envious people, and he trusted that, and his two arms, and the price of lace, and nothing else.

Faris shouted *Abu Zayd!* and the ball went a foot wide of the can. Mikhail crossed himself and said what he said and the can went over into the grass.

It was not the words, Faris told himself. Mikhail had a good eye. But he watched. He watched for a whole week from the side of the barn, how Mikhail stood still before he threw, how something in his face went quiet, as if he had gone into another room, and how out of that quiet the ball went straight. And one evening when nobody was looking, when the others had gone in and he was throwing alone at the can in the long yellow light that lasts until ten o'clock in a Dakota July, he crossed himself, badly, left before right, and said it.

The can went over.

He said it the next throw, and the next. He said it under his breath for the rest of that summer, throwing at the can, carrying water from the slough, lying on his pallet at night listening to his father snore. He said it when he was frightened and when he was bored and when there was nothing at all in his head, until it was like a stone he carried in his pocket and turned over without knowing. He did not say it in front of his father.

Old Imm Jirjis saw him at it once, from the road. She was walking past with her case on her back, as she had walked the roads of four states for twenty years, a little brown woman in a black dress with a kerchief over her hair and a man's shoes. She stopped and watched him throw. She did not say anything. She only nodded, the way you nod at somebody doing a job right, and went on toward the Saba house to sell Mikhail's mother a paper of needles.

II. The Coal Bank

The road to Lindahl · September 1907

Assaad Malouf had gone up in the world. He had a team now, two bay geldings he called Hamdan and Zayd, and a spring wagon with a box built on behind the seat that opened out like a cupboard, and in the cupboard there were drawers: needles and pins, thread on wooden spools, buttons on cards, shoelaces, suspenders, combs, mirrors, a drawer of lace that the women of the colony had made over the winter, a drawer of little olive-wood crosses and rosaries from Jerusalem that he sold to the Catholics and laughed at in Arabic as soon as he was out of the yard. He had a county license for a single horse, which cost thirty-five dollars a year, and drove two, and dared anybody to count.

Every fall he took Faris out with him for a week on the circuit, west and north among the Norwegian farms, to learn the trade. Faris learned to stand in a farm kitchen and open the drawers one at a time, slowly, so the lace came last. He learned to say *Good morning, Missus* and *very fine* and *for you, special.* He learned that the Norwegian women would buy anything if you let them look long enough, and that they would give you coffee whether you wanted it or not, and a piece of lefse, and sometimes,

when the man was out, ask you in a low voice whether you had anything for female trouble.

On the last day of the week they turned for home by way of a coal bank on a coulee south of Lindahl. Everybody on the flats burned lignite. There was no wood on that prairie worth the name, only the willows along the creek, and the lignite lay in a black seam right in the bank of the coulee where the water had cut it, so soft you could dig it with a spade. The Norwegian who owned the quarter let his neighbors dig their own for a dollar a wagonload. Assaad paid him the dollar, and he and Faris dug all afternoon, the boy in the seam with the spade and the man on the wagon spreading the load so it rode level, and the coal was brown-black and smelled of old leaves when you broke it, and in some of the chunks you could still see the grain of the wood it had been, a long time ago, when it was a tree.

A tree, Faris said, holding one up.

A tree, said his father. *And then it lay down, and then it was coal, and now we burn it, and then it's ash. And Abu Zayd is dead too. Throw it in the wagon.*

The wagon was heavy and the geldings were tired, and it was near sundown when they came up out of the coulee within sight of Lindahl. Lindahl was a Great Northern town of four hundred people, a depot and two elevators and a Lutheran church with a white steeple, and on the north side of it, where the colony road came in, a man named Elias Haddad kept the only Syrian store between Minot and the Montana line. Haddad was the dealer. He had brought most of the colony out, one cousin at a time. He stocked their cases on credit and they paid him back in the fall, and his word was law on the flats in a way no sheriff's was. He was the one who wrote their letters and read the ones that came. He had a cast-iron safe and a gold watch and a brass tray from Damascus as wide as a wagon wheel, with verses from the old poets running around its rim in letters inlaid with silver.

That night was the eve of the Feast of the Cross. Haddad kept it every year in the old way, and the whole colony came in to his store for it, the women a day ahead to cook. Latifeh Malouf had gone in on the Sabas' wagon the morning before. Assaad had not gone. He had told her, in

front of the boy, that he would go and eat Haddad's lamb when Haddad came out and dug Haddad's own coal.

So they did not go into town. Assaad stopped the wagon a quarter mile short of it, where the road passed the Lutheran cemetery, because there was a well there with a pump and a trough for the people who drove out on Sundays, and good grass along the fence. He unhooked the traces and watered the geldings and hobbled them and gave them their oats in a nosebag each, and he and Faris ate bread and olives and the last of the cheese sitting on the wagon tongue, with their backs to the graves.

Off to the north, on the high ground past the edge of town, a fire went up. It was the bonfire for the Feast, which at home they lit on the hilltops so that one village could see the next one's, all the way down the valley. Here there was only the one. Faris watched it a long time, a red point on the dark prairie, the sparks going up off it.

III. Under the Wagon

The Lutheran cemetery outside Lindahl · that night

It was a cattle drive that did it. A rancher from up on the Missouri breaks was bringing a hundred head of steers in to the stockyards by the depot to load for St. Paul in the morning, and they came along the road in the dusk with two men riding behind them, and the geldings lifted their heads out of the nosebags and watched them pass. Then Zayd, who had always been the fool of the two, went after them, hobbles and all, in a kind of rocking hop, and Hamdan went after Zayd, and the two of them were carried away down the road into Lindahl in the dust and bawling, like two pieces of wood in a flood.

Assaad swore by everything Faris had ever heard him swear by and went after them on foot. *Stay with the wagon,* he shouted back. *Stay with the coal. Nobody touches it.*

Faris stayed with the wagon.

What happened in town he heard afterward. His father found the geldings without much trouble, in the corral behind the livery barn, where the steers had been turned in to wait for the cars. But the liveryman said

they had eaten his hay and wanted fifty cents, and Assaad had spent his last money on the coal, and he took a card of lace out of his coat and said, *For your wife, very fine, for you, special.* And the town marshal was standing in the door of the livery, a Norwegian named Bratlie with a star on his vest, and he said that was peddling, and the town of Lindahl had its own license for peddlers within the corporate limits, five dollars, and did Assaad have that one too, or only the county's.

Assaad had only the county's. He tried to explain about the horses, and the coal, and the boy at the cemetery, but when he was angry his English left him, and what was left was loud. They put him in the town lockup behind the depot for the night, to go before the justice in the morning. It was a plank building eight feet by ten with one barred window, and he stood at the window and shouted his son's name toward the cemetery until the marshal told him to shut up or he would gag him.

Faris did not hear him. A quarter of a mile is a long way on the prairie when the wind is from the west.

He waited until it was full dark. The bonfire had burned down to a red eye on the hill. He heard the cattle bawling in the stockyards, and a dog, and once the Great Northern going through without stopping, its headlight sweeping across the cemetery fence and the white stones, and then nothing. He was not afraid, at first. He was eleven and he had been left with the wagon before. He took the horse blanket off the seat and crawled under the wagon between the wheels, where the coal smell was and the dry grass was soft, and pulled the blanket over him, and lay looking at the bottom boards of the wagon bed. He said it a few times, under his breath, the way he had all summer. Then he slept.

• • •

The women on the flats had a word for what lived in graveyards, and every child of the colony knew it. The ghoul. In the stories the grandmothers told, the ghoul lay up in the ruins and the burying grounds outside the villages and ate the dead, and when the dead ran short it took the living, and it could look like anything it wanted: a camel, a goat, an old woman, your own cousin calling you by name in the dark. The grand-

mothers said it had come over to America in the steerage like everybody else. They said it hid in the bedding.

There were two of them in the cemetery outside Lindahl that night, Faris said later, and he never said otherwise, not when he was a grown man, not when he was old. He did not see their faces. He heard them over him in the dark, talking in Arabic, the Arabic of the mountain villages, which nobody in Lindahl but the Syrians could have spoken.

Look what they left us, said the one.

Let him alone, said the other. *He's a child. Get away from him.*

He's left. Nobody left him for you.

Then there were hands on his ankles, cold and very strong, and he was being drawn out from under the wagon into the open on his back, the blanket bunching under him, the grass going by, the stars coming out over him one after another as the wagon bed slid away. And out of him, before he knew he had it to say, came the thing he had said ten thousand times at the tomato can.

Ya Rabb, irham.

The hands let go. He heard whatever it was go backward through the grass a long way, fast, the way a cat goes from water.

Then it was quiet, and the other one spoke, close by him, low. *We did a wrong thing. It will be paid for. Lie still.*

He lay still. He felt himself lifted under the arms and set back under the wagon, out of the wind, the blanket pulled straight and tucked under his feet. Somebody went away and came back. There was a smell of bread, and of lamb and onions and cinnamon, and he was sat up and held against somebody's shoulder while a cup of water was put to his mouth, and then pieces of food, kibbeh still warm from the oven and bread folded around it, the way his mother did it when he was sick, a mouthful and then another, and a man's coat that smelled of tobacco and horse was put over him on top of the blanket. Somebody sat by his head and somebody sat by his feet. He thought, *My mother has come out from town. My father has come back with Hamdan and Zayd.* And because they were there he was not afraid of anything, and he lay down again and slept like a stone.

A Norwegian dairyman named Ole Fosse, driving his milk cans in to the depot before light, said afterward that as he came along the cemetery road he saw two people standing by the Syrian wagon, one at the front wheel and one at the back, very still, like fence posts. He said he took them for the peddler and his wife. He said that when he came up even with the wagon there was nobody there but a boy asleep underneath it with his arm over his face, and he did not think anything of it until later, when it was all over town, and then he thought about it the rest of his life.

Faris woke when the sun came over the edge of the prairie and lay flat across the grass into his eyes. He was alone. There was no coat on him. There was the horse blanket, and the dew on it, and the smell of coal.

> *I laid me down and slept, and rose up again; for the Lord sustained me. I will not be afraid for ten thousands of the people, that have set themselves against me round about.*
>
> *— Psalm 3:5–6*

He crawled out and stood up and stretched, and that was when he saw the tray. It was lying on top of the coal in the wagon bed, catching the first sun. Brass, as wide as a wagon wheel, with a few crumbs of bread on it and a smear of grease where the kibbeh had been, and silver letters running all around the rim.

IV. The Tray

Lindahl · the Feast of the Cross

The Haddad women had set out the feast the night before, as they did every year, on the big tray on the table in the back room of the store, so that it would be ready for the morning: the kibbeh in its pan, the stuffed cabbage, the bread, the olives from the barrel that came out from New York, the white cheese, the honey cakes, everything under a clean cloth. In the morning the cloth was lying folded on the table and the tray was gone with everything on it.

Elias Haddad's wife screamed. Then Haddad's clerk ran for the marshal, and the marshal, who had already had one Syrian in his lockup that night, said he knew where to look for Syrian thieves. They went through the stockyards and the livery and the section house and the depot. Then they went out the cemetery road.

They brought Faris back walking between the marshal and the clerk, the clerk carrying the tray in both arms against his chest like a shield. Half of Lindahl followed them up the street, and the whole of the colony was waiting in front of the store in their feast clothes. Latifeh Malouf came running out through the door with flour on her arms and stopped when she saw who it was. At the same moment, from the other end of the street, Assaad came up from the justice's office, released, with the lace still in his pocket, because the justice was a practical man who had decided that a Syrian with no money was not worth the board of a Syrian in jail.

So the three of them came together in front of the store, the boy and the man and the woman, from three directions, and stood there.

Elias Haddad came out onto the step. He was a heavy man with a grey mustache and a gold chain across his vest, and he looked at the boy, and at the father, whom he had not seen at his feast in four years, and he held out his hands for the tray.

The clerk gave it to him. And Haddad saw the letters.

They were cut into the brass inside the old inlaid verses, in the plain open center where the food went, new and bright in the dark of the old metal, the way a fresh scratch shows bright on a pan. They were Arabic. Haddad turned the tray to the light and read them, and his lips moved, and his face changed.

The clerk had looked at the tray all the way up the street and said afterward that there was nothing on it but scratches, like a hen had walked on it. Haddad's wife looked and saw scratches. Hanna Saba the chanter, who read Arabic better than anybody on the flats, looked over Haddad's shoulder and saw scratches. Haddad read it to nobody. He told it once, many years later, to the boy, when the boy was a grown man, and the boy told it to nobody either, until he was old.

What it said, as near as anybody knows, was this: *Elias son of Mikhail. A child of yours was put outside the gate in the dark, and his father shut in, and the dead were hungry. We fed him from your table. We have paid for it with fear. Keep him.*

Haddad was quiet a long time. Then he said to the boy, in Arabic, very gently, *Habibi. What is this?*

I don't know, Ammo, said Faris. *I didn't take anything. I slept under the wagon. My mother and my father came in the night and gave me something to eat and put a coat on me and sat with me. I thought, my mother and father are here, and I wasn't afraid, and I went to sleep. That's all I know.*

Latifeh put her hand over her mouth. Assaad stood in the street and looked at his son and then at his own empty hands, and did not say anything at all. Everybody in the colony knew where Latifeh had slept that night, on a pallet in Haddad's back room with four other women. Everybody in Lindahl knew where Assaad had slept.

The marshal asked what the writing said. Haddad said it was a verse about hospitality, from the old poets, and that the tray was not stolen, it had been lent, and he had forgotten, and he apologized to the marshal for the trouble and invited him in to eat, and the marshal, who knew when he was being told to go away, went away.

V. Six

The back room of the Haddad store

Imm Jirjis had come in for the Feast on the Saba wagon, as she did every year, and she was sitting in the back room by the stove with a cup of coffee, where it was warm, because she was old and the cold got into her now. She had walked for twenty years with that case on her back, from Duluth to Havre, through the Red River Valley in the mosquitoes and the Montana high line in the snow, sleeping in haystacks and barns and on the kitchen floors of women who could not say her name. Her husband had died of a fever in a boarding house in St. Paul the first year. Her son, the Jirjis she was mother of, nobody in the colony had ever seen; he had died in the old country before she came, or had not, nobody

KNEW, AND NOBODY ASKED. SHE DID NOT PEDDLE ANYMORE. She lived in a claim shack on the Saba quarter and did the Sabas' mending, and when anybody on the flats was in trouble they went and sat with her, and came away feeling as though they had been to church.

Haddad brought them in to her, the three Maloufs, and set the tray on the table in front of her, and the whole colony came crowding into the doorway behind.

He told her all of it. The ball and the tomato can, which Hanna Saba told him; the cattle and the livery and the lockup; the boy under the wagon; the hands on his ankles; the word. He did not tell her what the tray said. She did not ask.

Imm Jirjis, he said. *He had one word. Lord, have mercy. He said it and the thing let go of him. Is it only that word that keeps us? Or is there more?*

She drank her coffee. She was quiet so long that the children in the doorway began to shift. Then she set down the cup.

That word is enough, she said. *It held him. But it's one door, Elias. The house has six.*

She held up her hand and counted them on her fingers, the way she used to count spools for a farm wife.

Remember the Lord. Day and night. That's the boy's word.

Remember what He said. The Gospel. The psalms. Have them in your mouth when you're walking.

Remember the people. The church. Not the building, we haven't got one. Us. The ones in this room and the two out at the corner of the Saba place under the boards, and the Norwegians in their graveyard too.

Remember your body. She touched her own chest with her thumb. *Bones and blood and the lungs going in and out. It came over in the steerage and it's going in the ground like theirs. Don't forget it for a day.*

Hurt nothing. She looked at Assaad when she said this, and then away. *Not a horse. Not a dog. Not a Norwegian marshal. Not a priest, either.*

She had one finger left. She folded it down slowly.

And pray. Sit still and pray, morning and night, until the praying goes on by itself and you're only listening to it.

A man who keeps one of those, any one, day and night, doesn't need a blue bead, she said. *He doesn't need a gun or a lawyer or a license or a charm from the Moghrabi. Six. Like the six psalms at Matins, that the reader reads in the dark before the light comes, when the priest stands before the altar praying to himself and nobody in the church moves.* And she said a piece of one of them, in the old church Arabic, in her cracked voice, so that Hanna Saba, standing in the door, joined in on the second line without meaning to.

> *Have I not remembered thee in my bed, and thought upon thee when I was waking? Because thou hast been my helper; therefore under the shadow of thy wings will I rejoice.*
>
> *— Psalm 63:7–8*

Then she picked up her cup again and found it empty and looked into it.

Assaad Malouf reached under his collar and found the string with the blue bead on it and broke it with one pull, and put the bead on the table beside the tray. Nobody in the room said anything. Latifeh took his arm. Faris stood between them and looked at the bright scratches in the middle of the tray that he could not read, and that nobody but Haddad could read, and felt, he said later, the way he had felt under the wagon with somebody sitting at his head and somebody at his feet.

VI. Matins

The flats · 1907 and after

Assaad went to Haddad's feast that day, and ate the lamb, and told the story of Abu Zayd afterward to the children in the long rhymed lines until they fell asleep on the floor. He kept telling it all his life. But that winter, on the Sundays when the colony met in Hanna Saba's front room to say the prayers with no priest, he came, and stood at the back with his hat in his hands, and on the third Sunday, when Hanna got to the six psalms and his voice gave out with a cold, Assaad Malouf, who said priests ate the first lamb and the last, read them in his place, in the dark before the lamp was lit, from memory, because he had heard

THEM EVERY MORNING OF HIS BOYHOOD IN THE VILLAGE AND had never once forgotten a word.

He took out a second license that spring, for two horses, fifty dollars. Latifeh asked him why, when nobody had ever counted. He said he had counted.

Imm Jirjis died in the hard winter of 1911, in the claim shack, with the stove going. Latifeh had been sitting with her. In the spring Latifeh took the old case down from its nail, and filled it, and put it on her back, and walked the county with it for eleven years, and the farm wives who could not say her name said afterward that she would come into a kitchen and open the drawers one at a time, slowly, and sit, and that somehow you told her things.

When Latifeh died, Assaad sold the claim and the team and the wagon and went east, an old man, to a monastery in the Pennsylvania hills that the Russian bishop had started for the Orthodox of America, and lived out his life there cutting wood. He wrote to his son once a year. The letters were short and in Arabic and were mostly about the weather and the wood. The last one said, *I am still saying the boy's word.*

Faris went east too, years before, on Haddad's money, and studied, and was ordained, and served parishes in Ohio and Michigan and Iowa for fifty-one years. Mikhail Saba stood up at his ordination. In every parish the boys knew that if you went out in the churchyard after Vespers the old priest would come out in his cassock and play catch with you until it was too dark to see the ball, and that before every throw he would go still for a moment, as if he had stepped into another room, and say something under his breath that you could not quite hear.

Elias Haddad left him the tray. It came to him in a crate in 1934, with a letter from the lawyer in Williston, and he hung it on the wall of his kitchen in the rectory in Toledo, where he could see it from the table. Parishioners who came for coffee admired the old silver verses around the rim and asked what the scratches in the middle were. He said a child had done that. He got up at four every morning of his life, and before he went over to the church to read Matins he sat at that table in the dark with his coffee, under the tray, and said the six psalms through once to himself,

and by the time he got to the end of them the window was grey, and then it was light, and the light came across the kitchen and found the scratches in the brass and lit them up one at a time, like somebody writing.

Background

The verses

> *The disciples of Gotama (Buddha) are always well awake, and their thoughts day and night are always set on Buddha.*
>
> Dhammapada 296, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The disciples of Gotama are always well awake, and their thoughts day and night are always set on the law.*
>
> Dhammapada 297, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The disciples of Gotama are always well awake, and their thoughts day and night are always set on the church.*
>
> Dhammapada 298, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

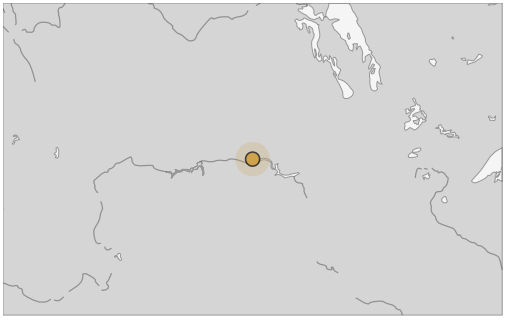
> *The disciples of Gotama are always well awake, and their thoughts day and night are always set on their body.*
>
> Dhammapada 299, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The disciples of Gotama are always well awake, and their mind day and night always delights in compassion.*
>
> Dhammapada 300, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The disciples of Gotama are always well awake, and their mind day and night always delights in meditation.*
>
> Dhammapada 301, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two boys of Rājagaha play ball. One calls out praise of the Buddha as he throws and always wins; the other, whose family follows another teacher, copies him until the recollection becomes his own. One evening the second boy's father, a wagon driver hauling firewood, stops near a charnel ground outside the city; the oxen wander through the gate, the father follows, and the gate is shut behind him. The boy sleeps alone under the wagon. Two spirits find him. One means to eat him and drags him by the feet, but when the boy cries out homage to the Buddha it falls back in terror. The other stands guard, and together, ashamed, they bring him

food in the king's golden dish, care for him "as would a mother and a father," and cut letters into the dish that only the king can read. In the morning the boy is arrested as a thief and says only that his parents came in the night. The king takes the boy and his parents to the Buddha and asks whether recollection of the Buddha is the only protection; the Buddha answers with six verses naming six recollections, and all three later reach awakening. Read the full commentary story.



Williams County, North Dakota

Syrians in North Dakota, 1907

Arabic-speaking immigrants from Ottoman Syria, most of them from the villages of Mount Lebanon and the Bekaa, began arriving in the United States in numbers in the 1880s, and many started out as peddlers, carrying cases of notions, lace and religious goods from farm to farm. In North Dakota the peddlers came first and sent word home about free land; in the early 1900s more than 350 Syrians took up homesteads in the state, Christians and Muslims both. A peddler there needed a county license under the state's 1895 peddling act: twenty dollars a year on foot, thirty-five with one horse, fifty with two, with up to thirty days in the county jail for peddling without one, and incorporated towns kept the right to license peddlers on top of that. Fuel on the treeless western prairie was lignite, which lay exposed in coulee banks; some landowners simply opened the seam and let neighbors dig their own for a dollar a wagonload.

Orthodox Syrians on the plains rarely saw a priest. Raphael Hawaweeny, consecrated in New York in 1904 as the first Orthodox bishop consecrated in North America, spent years traveling by train and on foot to scattered Arabic-speaking communities and established some thirty parishes; between his visits, laymen led the prayers. Matins (Orthros) in the Orthodox Church begins with the Six Psalms, read before daylight while the church stands still. The psalms quoted in the story are in the Coverdale translation as printed in the English *Service Book of the Holy Orthodox-Catholic Apostolic Church* published in 1906 by Isabel Hapgood. The Feast of the Exaltation of the Cross, in September, is kept in Syria and Lebanon with bonfires on

the hilltops, recalling the chain of fires said to have carried the news of the Cross's finding from Jerusalem to Constantinople.

After the story of the son of a wagon driver from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 296–301). The original. Scripture from the Psalter (Coverdale) as printed in Isabel Hapgood's *Service Book of the Holy Orthodox-Catholic Apostolic Church* (1906). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.6

The Night Show

How dreary to be somebody!
How public, like a frog
— Emily Dickinson, Poems, Second Series (1891)

The way I heard it, out north of town.

I. Forty Acres

North of Cheyenne, Wyoming · 2012–2018

When Dale Lerwick died in the spring of 2012 the ranch was supposed to go to Cass. Everybody in Laramie County knew it. Her brother Wade had been gone to the Bakken since the boom started and said he was never coming back to look at the back end of a cow, and her cousin Travis had his own place on Horse Creek and his own note at the bank. Cass had grown up in the calving shed. She had shown a steer at the county fair every August from nine to eighteen and had cried in the sale barn every time and sold him anyway, the way you were supposed to. She could rope. Her father had left the brand to her in his will by name, a bar over an L, which in that country was as close as a man came to crowning somebody.

She had also quit eating meat at nineteen, her second year at the university in Laramie, and quit milk and eggs two years after that. Nobody in the family had taken it seriously. Her father said it was a thing girls did in college, and when it lasted he said it was a thing she did, and he never once said anything about it at the table. When he was dying he asked her what she would do with the place, and she told him, and he looked at the ceiling of the hospital room for a long time and said, *Well, they're yours.*

She sold the herd that fall to Travis at a fair price, and leased him the grass, and deeded him the home place and the shed and the corrals for a dollar, because he had three kids and she had none. She kept forty acres at the bottom end where the creek came in under a stand of cottonwoods, and she kept the oldest of her father's cows, eleven of them, who were past calving and would have gone to the sale barn in the fall anyway. That was the beginning. Within three years she had nineteen cattle, most of them steers from 4-H kids who could not stand to put theirs through the sale ring and whose parents had driven them out to her at night with the trailer lights off, as if it were something to be ashamed of. She had goats, and two pigs from a family that had moved to Fort Collins, and a white turkey, and a gray gelding named Smoke who had bucked in the bareback string for eleven years and then stopped. She lived in a single-wide with a woodstove. She ate lentils and rice and whatever was in the garden. On the internet, where she posted pictures of the steers, eleven thousand strangers loved her. In Cheyenne a great many people who had known her since she was born had found it was easier not to stop when they saw her at the Albertsons.

She was not sorry. She had never once been sorry. It was only that for six years she had gone to bed every night at nine with the steers breathing at the fence, and there was nobody on earth who would have called that a life but her.

II. The Last Saturday

The forty acres · July 28, 2018, after midnight

Frontier Days ran ten days at the end of July, and on the last Saturday night the whole town was out. Cheyenne had been hung with flags since the cattle drive two Sundays back. There had been four parades and three free pancake breakfasts, where the Kiwanis fed forty thousand people off griddles the size of a pickup bed. There had been rodeo every afternoon, and every afternoon the north wind had brought her the announcer's voice from Frontier Park in pieces, the names of cowboys and the names of their hometowns, so that she could hear a man

FROM TEXAS AND A MAN FROM ALBERTA GO BY ON THE AIR without hearing what had happened to them. Travis was on the rodeo committee and had been in a white straw hat and a pressed shirt for nine days. Her sister-in-law had a new one for every night.

The Saturday night show let out a little after eleven. She could hear the end of it from her step, the bass more than the song, and then the crowd, and then the whole grandstand walking to its trucks. The midway ran until midnight, and above the lights of the town she could see the top of the Ferris wheel turning, and then it stopped. After that there were the bars downtown and the campers out at the park, and the music came and went on the wind until nearly four. Every person she had gone to school with was in it somewhere. She knew how it smelled in there, funnel cake and diesel and beer on plywood. She had danced in that beer tent at seventeen in a new hat and had her boots stepped on by a boy from Chugwater.

She had done the water at ten and gone to bed and not slept, and at one she got up and pulled on the coveralls and went back out.

She walked the fence the way she walked it every night, down the lane from the trailer to the creek and back, the whole length of the forty, about a hundred steps. The moon was a night past full. It had come up over the plains enormous and orange and had climbed since then as high as it would go, small and white over the south, so that the posts threw short black shadows. The steers were lying down. One or two of them lifted their heads as she passed and put them down again. At the bottom of the lane she stopped by the cottonwoods where she had scattered her mother's ashes in 2009, and looked at herself in the moonlight. Canvas coveralls with the knees gone through, rubber boots, a ball cap with a feed-store name on it, her father's old work jacket. Hair that smelled of goat. She thought she looked like a post somebody had pulled out of a fence and thrown in the creek, the kind you find in the willows in the spring and leave.

Out loud, to nobody, to the cottonwoods, she said, *Who's worse off than me tonight? Name one.*

Something answered her out of the trees.

It was her mother's voice. Ellen Lerwick had taught English at Central High School for thirty-one years, and she had a voice for reading aloud that made fifteen-year-old boys from the base sit still, and Cass had not heard it since 2009 and knew it in the first word. It did not come from any one place in the cottonwoods. It said the poem her mother had put on the board on the first day of every school year, the one she said was for the ones who sat in the back:

I'm nobody! Who are you?
Are you nobody, too?
Then there's a pair of us — don't tell!
They'd banish us, you know.
How dreary to be somebody!
How public, like a frog
To tell your name the livelong day
To an admiring bog!
— Emily Dickinson, Poems, Second Series (1891)

Then it said, in the voice her mother used at home, *Honey, half that crowd would trade you tonight. They'd give the truck. They'd give the hat. Go to bed.*

The steers had all lifted their heads and were looking at the cottonwoods. Smoke had come down to the fence with his ears up. Then the wind brought another piece of somebody's music from town, and the cottonwoods were just cottonwoods, and the steers put their heads down one at a time and Smoke went off. Cass stood there a long time. She did not go to bed.

III. Dr. Kopp

Chugwater road · Sunday

Ardith Kopp had been a large-animal vet in southeast Wyoming since 1966, when she was the only woman in her class at Colorado State and men in three counties would not let her touch a cow. She

WAS SEVENTY-SIX NOW AND STILL WENT OUT, THOUGH SHE HAD given up pregnancy-checking in the winter of 2015 and said her shoulder was glad of it. She had married a rancher on the Chugwater who died young and left her eight hundred head and a note at the bank, and she had run the place for nine years and then sold it and lived alone since, in a stone house on the Chugwater road with a heeler and a shelf of journals. She had floated the teeth of every horse Cass ever owned. She had put down Cass's father's old cows one at a time as they went, out on the forty acres, and never once asked Cass what she thought she was doing.

Cass drove up on Sunday afternoon, the last day, when the whole county was at the final round of the rodeo. Dr. Kopp was on her porch with iced tea. Cass told her the whole thing, the music and the post in the creek and what she had said out loud. She told her about the voice too. She had thought on the drive up that she would leave that part out, and then she did not.

Dr. Kopp listened to the end. She looked out at the road for a while, where there was nobody.

Well, it's hard to quit, she said. *You know that. Quitting the place, quitting all of it. That's hard, and it doesn't stop being hard, and then on top of that you're supposed to like it, and some nights you don't. That's the first two.*

But don't you think for one minute that Travis is sitting in that grandstand having a good time. That man has eight hundred cows and the price of hay and a note at the bank, and three kids, and a wife who wants a new hat every night. I had that. I had it nine years. Staying is hard too.

And living with people who don't see it your way. Your brother at Thanksgiving. Me with my husband's mother in the house for six years. You with half of Cheyenne. That's hard whichever side of the fence you're on.

She drank some of the tea.

And the worst one is going round and round. Quit, go back, quit again. Lie there at night and go round on it. I've watched people do that with a ranch for forty years and I've watched them do it with a bottle and with a husband. It's the going round that wears you out. Not the place.

So don't go round, she said. *That's all I know.*

Cass sat on the porch step with her tea and looked at the empty road. Something went out of her shoulders that had been in them since about 2012, maybe longer, maybe since the sale barn when she was nine. It was not that she had decided anything. There was nothing to decide. The post she had seen the night before in the moonlight was only a post. The music in town was only music, and the people in it were having the night they were having, and she was having hers, and none of them was worse off than any other, and every one of them was. She could not have said it any better than that, and she never tried to.

Who was it you heard, said Dr. Kopp after a while, *your mother?*

Yes ma'am.

Ellen was a good teacher, said Dr. Kopp. *I took a night class from her at the college in 1981. She made us learn that one.*

IV. The Float

The forty acres · Monday morning

On Monday the carnival trucks went north up the interstate past the forty acres from six in the morning on, flatbeds with the Ferris wheel folded down on them in sections and the cars of the Zipper chained on in a row. Cass was out at the stock tank in the coveralls with the hose. She looked up at them once.

The steers came down to drink while the tank filled. There was a float valve that clipped on the rim, a brass arm and a copper ball, that her father had bought when she was a child, and in six years she had never once let it do its job; she always stood at the tank with the hose and shut the hydrant off by hand when the water was high enough. That morning she clipped the float on and walked away to feed the goats.

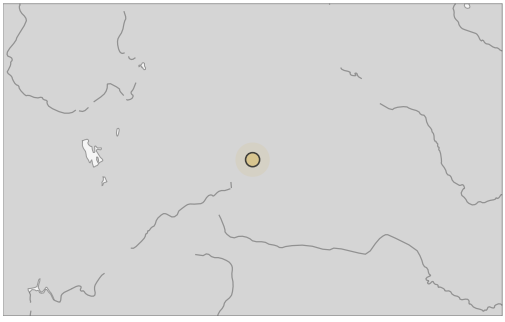
When she came back the tank was full to the brim and still. The ball had come up with the water and shut it off by itself, and the steers were drinking it down, and as they drank the ball sank a little and the water came in again under it, just as much as they had taken, and no more.

Background

The verse

> *It is hard to leave the world (to become a friar), it is hard to enjoy the world; hard is the monastery, painful are the houses; painful it is to dwell with equals (to share everything in common) and the itinerant mendicant is beset with pain. Therefore let no man be an itinerant mendicant and he will not be beset with pain.*
>
> Dhammapada 302, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Vajjian prince gives up his turn to rule and becomes a monk in a forest grove near Vesālī. On the full-moon night of Kattika the whole city is hung with banners and keeps festival until morning, and the monk, walking his cloister under the moon in his plain robe, hears the drums and lutes and thinks he looks like a log thrown away in the forest. Who, he asks, is worse off than we are? The spirit who lives in the grove answers him in verse: many envy you, as those in hell envy those bound for heaven. The next day he goes to the Buddha, who names the five kinds of suffering in this verse: the going forth is hard, delight in it is hard, the household life is hard, living with the uncongenial is hard, and the traveler through the round of births is beset by suffering; so do not be a traveler. Hearing it, the monk is freed. Read the full commentary story. The same exchange with the forest spirit is told in the Saṁyutta Nikāya (SN 9.9). The mother's poem is Emily Dickinson's "I'm Nobody! Who are you?", quoted as it was printed in *Poems, Second Series* in 1891.



North of Cheyenne, Wyoming

Cheyenne, 2018

Cheyenne Frontier Days began in 1897 as a one-day cowboy roundup and calls itself "the Daddy of 'em All." It runs ten days around the last full week of July, with rodeo every afternoon, a concert in the arena every night, a carnival midway, parades, and three free pancake breakfasts put on by the Kiwanis that feed some 40,000 people a year. It is run by committees of more than 2,500 volunteers from the town. In 2018 it

ran from July 20 to 29; the last night show was on Saturday, July 28, and the midway stayed open until midnight. The moon had been full the night before, during a total lunar eclipse that could not be seen from North America.

Farm Sanctuary, founded in 1986 and calling itself America's first shelter for farmed animals, rescues cattle, pigs, goats and poultry and keeps them for the rest of their lives, and it promotes veganism, which refuses meat, milk and eggs alike; smaller farm-animal sanctuaries on the same pattern, some of them run by one or two people, have since been started across the country. In ranching country the ordinary way is otherwise. A 4-H member raises a market steer for most of a year and sells it at auction at the county fair, and the sale is meant to teach where meat comes from.

After the story of the Vajjian monk from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 302). The original. Poem by Emily Dickinson, from *Poems, Second Series* (1891). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.7

The Bread Truck

> *For him all doors are flung wide; him all tongues greet, all honors crown, all eyes follow with desire.*
> *— Emerson, "Self-Reliance"*

This is how it was shared with me, on Old State Road 37.

I. Side One

Bloomington, Indiana · 1977 to 1987

Hart Householder had the natural foods store on the west side of Bloomington, in the long tin building that had been his father's feed mill. He had started with one barrel of brown rice in 1971 and by the middle eighties he was selling bulk grain and beans to six counties, with a room of books on one side and a bulletin board by the door that people drove in from Nashville and Spencer to read. He was fifty-two. He gave credit and did not write it down. If a commune out past Needmore had a bad winter, a truck came up their lane, and nobody had to ask whose it was. People who had never been inside the store knew his name.

In the fall of 1977 a thin man came in off the highway with a pack. He did not ask for anything. He stood by the peanut grinder with his eyes down and waited to be in nobody's way, and there was something in how he stood that Hart liked. Hart took him in back and gave him lunch. Before he left, the man set a cassette on the table. It had a white label, typed: SITTING, NO. 1. MOUNT SHASTA, CALIF. No name was on it.

Hart played it that night on the machine in the office. It was a woman, not young, with a dry little cough she had not bothered to cut out. Behind her a kitchen clock ticked, and once a dog shook itself.

Sit down, she said. *You don't need to bring anything. Let the breath go out, and see whether anything is missing.*

That was nearly all of it, for thirty minutes. At the end she said, *Now turn the tape over,* and the other side was the same thing done again, a little slower.

He wrote to the box number. The tapes were four dollars and there were, in the end, thirty-one of them. There was no catalog and no photograph, and the only name he ever had was on the back of his cancelled checks: E. Varnum, in a schoolgirl hand. He kept the tapes in a shoebox by the register and sold them for what he paid. By 1985 half the people who sat still on purpose anywhere south of Indianapolis had started on No. 1 out of that box.

That year two of her old students came through on their way east, a nurse and a carpenter, and Hart went out to the edge of town to meet their car. The carpenter was the thin man with the pack, eight years older. They were tired. They talked for an hour in the book room anyway, to forty people on folding chairs, and what they said was plain enough that he could not afterward repeat it. But something in him that had always leaned a little toward the next place, the next thing, sat back on its heels that night and did not get up again.

II. The Patch

Bloomington · June 10, 1987

Behind the feed mill four acres ran down to a creek, and the bottom of it was pawpaws, a whole grove, growing in their own shade the way they do. People had been going down there to sit for years. In June of 1987 Hart had a lawyer draw a paper giving the four acres to a little board, to be kept open to anybody from any direction who wanted to sit down and be quiet, with a shed for rain.

He signed it on a card table in the patch on a Wednesday evening, with the board standing around him and the lawyer swatting mosquitoes.

Well, Hart said, capping the pen, *that's planted.*

The ground shook. The card table walked a foot to the left. Every leaf in the grove shivered with no wind, and up in the store a row of honey jars went off the shelf one after another. It was twelve minutes before seven. Radios said afterward that it was an earthquake under Olney, Illinois, the biggest in those parts in nineteen years, and that it was felt in seventeen states. The people who had been standing in the pawpaw patch heard that and nodded and kept their own opinion.

That night Hart sat in the office with the shoebox.

I learned the first thing from her and never saw her, he thought. *I learned the second thing from her people and never saw her. I ought to see her.*

In the morning there was a card on the bulletin board. GOING TO MOUNT SHASTA TO SEE MRS. VARNUM. LEAVING AUGUST 1. ANYBODY WHO WANTS TO COME, COME. YOU WON'T NEED MONEY. H.H.

Everyone who read it said the same thing: he was going for the Convergence. All that summer the newspapers were full of it, the sixteenth and seventeenth of August, when a hundred and forty-four thousand people were supposed to stand on the high places of the earth at sunrise and hum a new age in, and Mount Shasta was one of the places. Hart had read about it too.

That as well, I guess, he said.

III. The Bread Truck

Indiana to California · August 1 to 15

He owned a step van that had delivered bread around Monroe County through the sixties. You could still read the bakery's name under the white paint when the sun was low. He loaded it himself. Twenty sacks of short-grain brown rice at fifty pounds, sesame seed and tahini in tins, ghee by the case, raw sugar. He put in drawstring trousers in all sizes and thirty quilts from the Tuesday women. It was for her, and for whoever was around her.

Forty-three people went. There was a church bus bought at auction and five cars behind the bread truck. There were Unity ladies in sun hats,

and two graduate students in religion, and a man who had laid track for the Monon, and a massage therapist with twin boys. There was a quiet veteran who drove the bus. Hart had laid in food for all of them for the whole road, in coolers, in the bus.

They never opened a cooler.

Outside St. Louis, at the first rest area, a family was standing by a picnic table with supper for fifty already set out, and said they had just had a feeling. At Unity Village the cafeteria would not take a dollar. In Kansas a Mennonite couple flagged the bus down from the shoulder with their trunk open. It went on like that. Boulder, Laramie, Rock Springs, a café in Wendover where the owner came out wiping his hands and said it was on him. A day's drive apart, about, there was somebody waiting. Nobody had called ahead. There was no one to call. The graduate students tried for a while to work out how it was being done and then stopped and ate.

People along the way gave them things besides: melons, a box of candles, a spare tire that fit the bus. Hart gave all of it away again at the next stop. The bread truck stayed shut with its hasp down for two thousand three hundred miles.

IV. Alder Street

Mount Shasta, California · Saturday, August 15

Esther Varnum was seventy-four. Her mother had taken her into the I AM classes in Los Angeles in the thirties, when half the city seemed to be in them. She had come north with the believers and walked in the first pageants. Somewhere in the fifties she stopped going, without a quarrel, and stayed on in a small house on Alder Street with a clock in the kitchen. She had never told anyone to buy a tape. A young man named Andy copied them for her in the garage and took the mail to the box.

On the Thursday she said to him, *Andy. Saturday, about when the shadows get long, the man from Indiana will pull in here with a bread truck.*

Will anything happen? He had been with her four years and had learned to ask.

Something will.

What?

Flowers. A good many. You may want to move your car.

Andy told one person. The town that week was full to the gutters with people who had come for the mountain, sleeping in vans and on the school lawn, and by Saturday afternoon a few hundred of them had found Alder Street and stood along both sides of it with their arms full of things they had brought in case. The television crews were all up the mountain road, waiting for Sunday's sunrise.

The bread truck came around the corner at ten to seven with the bus behind it. Hart got down. He asked the Unity ladies, who were the oldest, to come along at the back where they would not be jostled, and he went up the street on foot with the rest behind him. The ones who were there say the fence pickets hummed as he passed them, and that a porch swing three houses down started going by itself.

She was on her own porch in a housedress and a grey cardigan. He had thought for fifteen days about what he would say. He took off his cap and went down on one knee on the step, like a man tying a shoe, and put his two hands on her two feet in their canvas sneakers. He did not say anything.

The flowers came down then. There was no wind, and the sky was the clear green it goes over the mountain after sunset. They fell straight and thick like the first heavy snow. There were Shasta lilies and blue lupine and red paintbrush, and white phlox, and the little purple pennyroyal from the high meadows, all of them fresh. They fell for a quarter of an hour, from the railroad tracks to the grade school and nowhere else, and when they stopped they were over a grown person's knees. The twins waded in them. Several hundred people shouted, and then nobody could think what to shout next.

Come in, Mr. Householder, she said. He knew the cough. *Mind the step.*

V. The Garage

Alder Street · August and September

On Sunday the forty-three went up the mountain in the dark with everybody else and stood in a meadow and hummed the sun up. Mrs. Varnum did not go. *It comes down this street too,* she said, and sat at her kitchen table with the door open.

Hart stayed a month. He had meant to cook for her. He had meant to set up his pots in her yard and feed her out of his own sacks, with her neighbors and anyone who came by. But each morning there was food on the porch before he was up. There were plums and squash and bread still warm, eggs in a bowl with a cloth over them, a salmon once. It came from the people in the vans and from the mill families, and from the pageant ladies in their pale dresses, who had not spoken to her in thirty years. More came to him than to her. Strangers put things into his hands in the street. He cooked every day for sixty and seventy, and he never had to break the seal on a sack of his own.

On the fourteenth of September he stood in her kitchen with his cap in his hands.

Mrs. Varnum. I loaded that truck in Indiana to give you something. I was two weeks getting here, and I have been here a month, and I have not been able to give you one grain of it. Everything I've handed you, somebody handed me. If I stayed a year it would be the same. I'd like to empty the truck and go home. Tell me where I can put it.

Andy, she said, *clear him a place.*

Andy pushed the duplicating machine into a corner of the garage and swept. They carried in the rice and stacked it, and the tins and the ghee and the sugar, and the quilts on top with the trousers. It filled the garage to the rafters and left a path to the light switch.

He pulled out the next morning with the truck empty. He had got as far as the boulevard when people came out into the road. *Sir. You can't drive all that way with nothing in it.* They filled the bread truck where it stood. There were stones, mostly, since that was what that town had. Quartz points were wrapped in newspaper. There was amethyst and rose

quartz, and black obsidian from Glass Mountain. There was jade from the Klamath, turquoise, and a coffee can of river garnets. They added jars of blackberries and a rocking chair. The springs sat down on the axle.

All the way back, the forty-three ate from what had been given, and at every stop there was more.

VI. Terre Haute

Mount Shasta, and Bloomington · the end of September

Andy was sweeping petals out of the gutter. There were still petals. He came in and stood by the kitchen table.

Can I ask you something? He was two weeks coming and they fed him the whole way. He was a month here and couldn't spend a dime. He left empty and they filled him up in the street. Was that because he was coming to see you? I mean with the mountain, and the weekend it was. Would any of it have happened if he had been going somewhere else?

He has a sister in Terre Haute, Mrs. Varnum said. *If he had driven that truck to see her it would have gone just the same. It has nothing to do with me, and less than nothing to do with that weekend. A person who has kept faith for fifty years, and kept his word, and has something to give and is known for it, will be met like that wherever he sets his foot down. Hand me that.*

It was the one book she had brought with her out of her mother's house, from before the classes. She did not have to hunt for the place.

> *Welcome evermore to gods and men is the self-helping man. For him all doors are flung wide; him all tongues greet, all honors crown, all eyes follow with desire. Our love goes out to him and embraces him because he did not need it.*
>
> *— Emerson, "Self-Reliance"*

Because he did not need it, she said again. *You saw his face when he couldn't get that truck open.*

But why flowers? Andy said. *What did he ever do, to get flowers?*

She looked at the clock for a while.

I'll tell you one, and you can decide what it is. A long time back there was a hunter out in the rain. He saw a man sitting under a rock ledge with his coat pulled over his head, perfectly still. The hunter thought, that one is doing something, and he'll be hungry when he's done. So he went home and cooked yesterday's meat on one fire and rice on another. Some travelers came by his door while it cooked, and he fed them too. Then he carried a basket back through the wet, and on the way he picked whatever was blooming. He gave the man the food and laid the flowers down in front of him. And he said, I never was so glad of anything as I am of this. Wherever I come to after this, let me be as glad to be given things as I am now to give them. And let it rain flowers on my head.

Was that him?

It was somebody, said Mrs. Varnum. *Turn the tape over, Andy, it's run out.*

• • •

The bread truck came down Old 37 on the twenty-ninth of September. The stones went into bushel baskets by the store door with a sign that said TAKE ONE, and were gone by Thanksgiving.

Down in the patch the pawpaws were ripe. A pawpaw is not picked. It lets go when it is ready and comes down through the big leaves by its own weight. All that week there were people sitting in the grove with their eyes shut, and the fruit came down around them, one and then another. Nobody had to shake a tree.

Background

The verse

> *Whatever place a faithful, virtuous, celebrated, and wealthy man chooses, there he is respected.*
>
> Dhammapada 303, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Citta was a rich householder of Macchikāsaṇḍa. He fed a monk whose bearing pleased him, listened to him, and understood; he gave his own wild-mango grove to the monks, and the earth shook when he did. Later the two chief disciples came to see him, and from a short talk given by Sāriputta, who was tired from the road, he

reached the third stage of awakening. Having come so far without ever seeing the Buddha, he loaded five hundred carts with sesame, rice, ghee, sugar and cloth and invited anyone who wished to come along at his expense. For the month of the journey the gods fed the whole company at every league. When he bowed at the Buddha's feet, flowers rained knee-deep. For a month more he could give away only what others kept bringing him, and at last he asked for a place to unload his carts and started home with them empty, whereupon people filled them with jewels. Ānanda asked whether all this honor came because Citta had been visiting the Buddha. The Buddha said it would have been the same wherever he went, spoke the verse, and told of Citta's past life as a hunter who fed a meditating monk in the rain. The commentary gives the story in full at verses 73–74, with Citta's quarrel with the monk Sudhamma, and repeats its ending at the full commentary story for this verse. More about Citta.

Bloomington, Indiana, to Mount Shasta, California

Indiana and Mount Shasta, 1987

The Harmonic Convergence of August 16 and 17, 1987, was a worldwide synchronized meditation, and the newspapers covered it for weeks. Its organizers, reading a turning point into the Mesoamerican calendars, asked for 144,000 people to gather at "power centers" at sunrise, and Mount Shasta in northern California was among the chief of them. The mountain had been holy ground to American seekers for a long time. Guy Ballard said he met the master Saint Germain on its slopes, and the "I AM" Activity he founded with his wife claimed up to a million followers by 1938; its pageant has been held at Mount Shasta every August since 1950. Much New Age teaching in the 1970s and 1980s traveled by mail-order cassette and through the bulletin boards of natural-foods stores. Behind it stood the older current of New Thought, for which Emerson's essay "Self-Reliance" (1841) was close to scripture.

On the evening of June 10, 1987, an earthquake of magnitude 5.1 centered near Olney, Illinois, was felt in some seventeen states, the largest in that region since 1968. The pawpaw is the largest fruit native to North America, a relative of the tropical

custard apples that tastes something like mango and banana; it grows in shady patches along creek bottoms across southern Indiana and ripens at the end of September. Bloomington had communes in the hills around it and a food co-op from the 1970s. Hart Householder, his store, Mrs. Varnum and Alder Street are invented, and no one reported flowers.

After the story of the householder Citta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 303). The original. Quotation from Ralph Waldo Emerson, "Self-Reliance" (*Essays: First Series*, 1841). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

21.8

Eight Handfuls

Ye are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hid.
— Matthew 5:14 (Revised Version)

As I had it told me, up Mill Street.

I. The Promise

Camborne, Cornwall, and Grass Valley, California · 1852–1891

John Trevenna and Dick Uglow went down the same mine at Camborne the same week, at eleven years old, and learned their letters together at the same Sunday school in the same Wesleyan chapel, from an old tinner who had taught half the parish to read off the backs of hymnbooks. They were closer than brothers. One Sunday walking home over the downs, at fourteen, they shook hands on a thing they had heard men say in the count house. When we're grown and married, and have sons and daughters, if one of us asks the other for his daughter for his son, the other one shall give her.

Then the mines in Cornwall failed, the way they did in those years, and the two of them went where the Cornish went. John went to California, to the gold quartz at Grass Valley, where they said a mine was a hole in the ground with a Cornishman at the bottom of it. Dick went to Colorado. In forty years John rose to be a mine captain, the best-paid man underground in Nevada County, with a white house on the hill above Mill Street. Dick found silver at Leadville and became something nobody in Camborne had a word for, and built a house of red sandstone on Capitol Hill in Denver with a tower on the corner and a ballroom on the top floor.

John Trevenna had kept the chapel. Dick Uglow had not. He had kept the money.

In the spring of 1891 Dick Uglow came to Grass Valley in his own railroad car, with two engineers and a lawyer and a secretary, to look at a mine he was thinking of buying. He would not hear of the hotel. He stayed with John.

Your Uncle Dick has come, John said to his daughter. *He's as good as your father. See he has all a man should have in this house.*

Yes, Father.

Tamsin was nineteen. She did it herself. She baked the pasties for his dinner pail when he went down the mines with the engineers, with the initials in the crust the way her grandmother had done it in Camborne, and the saffron cake, and heavy cake for his tea. She had the water heated for his bath when he came up out of the shaft and laid out his clean things and saw his boots blacked. She did not hover, and she did not leave him wanting. When he spoke she listened, and when he was tired she let him be. Dick Uglow watched her for a week. On the last evening, sitting on the porch with his cigar, looking down on the lights of the stamp mills, he said to John, *You remember what we said on the downs, coming home from chapel. I've a son, Harry, twenty-four, at the bank. I'm asking.*

John Trevenna sat a long while.

Dick, he said, *you've gone a different road from me.*

I have. Ask me what I keep in my parlor of a Sunday, if you want to hear something.

John did not ask. He went the next evening up the hill to the cottage where Uncle Jabez Hocking lived and told him the whole of it.

Uncle Jabez was seventy-four. He had worked underground fifty years, in Cornwall and then in Grass Valley, and the dust of it was in his chest now, so that he could not climb a hill without stopping. For forty of those years he had been a local preacher of the Methodists, which is to say that he worked his shift all week and on Sunday walked to whatever chapel had no minister and preached for nothing, and had never once been paid a penny for it and would have been insulted to be offered. He did not preach long. Half of Grass Valley would walk out to Rough and Ready in the rain to hear him not preach long. Men said he had a way of being quiet that made a room quiet.

He heard John out. Then he said, *Let her go, John. Uglow will come round. There's more in him than he knows.*

II. The Gifts

Grass Valley · autumn 1891

They were married in the Methodist chapel in October. John Trevenna gave his daughter away the way men in Camborne talked about for years afterward, when the news reached them: a wagon of linen and plate and furniture, a piano, a set of china from Stoke with her initials on it, a gold brooch from a jeweler in San Francisco made in the shape of a peacock with a tail of seed pearls, a buggy and a pair of matched bays, and a deed to a block of shares. He gave a dinner to every man on his shift and every woman in the chapel, and to Uncle Jabez and all the preachers on the circuit, and sent a purse to the miners' hospital. People said it was as if he were showing the world what she had coming to her.

The night before she left, he sat with her in the front room and gave her his advice. She remembered it all her life and tried to write it down once and found it did not sound like much on paper.

Don't carry out of the house what goes on in it, and don't carry into it what goes on in the street. Lend to them as pays back. Don't lend to them as don't. But to some you'll give whether they pay or no, and you'll know which. Sit easy at table and eat easy and sleep easy, and don't let them see you fret. Keep the fire. And honor your husband's father and mother as if they were your own, in everything you can do with a clean heart.

And because she was going a thousand miles from anybody who knew her, he wrote to eight Cornishmen in Colorado whom he had known as boys, men who worked at Leadville and Central City and Black Hawk, and asked each of them to stand for her. *If any fault is ever laid against my girl in that house,* he wrote, *you go and hear it, and settle it fairly.* All eight wrote back yes.

She went east by the train, over the Sierra and across the desert and over the mountains, with her mother's sister to see her settled. At Denver

the whole Uglow household was at the depot to meet her, and a good many of Denver's people besides, because Dick Uglow had seen to it that they knew. She did not hurry from the depot to the house. She rode up Seventeenth Street and up the hill in an open carriage, in her traveling dress and her good hat, sitting straight, so that the town could look at her. The town looked. In the next weeks the wives on Capitol Hill sent her calling cards and cakes and a silver card case and a great many opinions, and she returned every call and sent each of them something chosen for that one woman and nobody else, a book, a shawl, a jar of her mother's quince jelly, and inside a month there was not a parlor on the Hill where they did not speak well of Harry Uglow's Cornish wife.

III. The Dark Room

Capitol Hill, Denver · winter 1891–1892

WHAT DICK UGLOW KEPT IN HIS PARLOR OF A SUNDAY WAS MEdiums.

He had come to it after his first wife died, the way a good many rich men did then. Now there were half a dozen of them who came to the house on Sundays and holidays and sat at his table and were paid. There was a Madame Vesper, who went into the cabinet, and a Professor Clary, who tied her in, and a pale young man who played the parlor organ in the dark, and others. On Thanksgiving and Christmas and New Year's they held a great circle in the ballroom at the top of the house, with the gas turned down to nothing and every guest holding the hands of the guests on either side, and out of Madame Vesper's black-curtained cabinet came the spirits in their muslin, glimmering, and walked among the circle and touched the sitters on the face. Dick Uglow believed his first wife came. He wept when she did.

Tell Harry's wife to come up, he sent word on Thanksgiving. *Tell her to come and pay her respects to our friends.*

Tamsin would not go. She could not look at them, she told her husband. She had seen Madame Vesper laughing in the back hall with her stockings rolled down and the muslin over her arm, and the professor

with his hand on her, and she knew what went on in that room with the gas out, between the men and the spirits, and she would not sit in the dark and hold hands with it.

At Christmas he sent again. At New Year's he sent again. At New Year's he came down himself, red in the face, and stood in her doorway.

Put her out, he said to Harry. *She'll not shame my friends in my house. Put her on the train.*

Nobody puts me out of this house without cause, Tamsin said. *And a fair hearing.*

She sent the telegrams herself that night. Within the week the eight came down from the mountains on the train, in their Sunday blacks, eight Cousin Jacks with their hats in their hands, and sat in a row in Dick Uglow's library under the elk heads. They heard him. They heard her. They went out together into the hall and talked a while, low, in the old way of talking, and came back in.

Mr. Uglow, said the eldest, a timberman from Central City, *we find no fault in her. She don't want to sit in the dark. We don't see that's a sin.*

Uglow looked at the eight of them a long time. He had been one of them once. *No,* he said at last. *No. All right.*

That night he said to his wife Grace, *She'll not do reverence to our friends. She says they've no shame.*

Grace Uglow was his second wife, a quiet woman from Ohio, who had sat through the circles on Sundays for nine years without a word and never once been touched on the face by anybody she knew. She went down the next morning and found Tamsin sewing in the window of the small parlor, and sat down across from her.

Tell me about your preachers, she said. *You must think a good deal of them, to stand up to Dick. What are they like?*

IV. Such Are My Preachers

The small parlor · the same morning

TAMSIN PUT HER SEWING DOWN.

They're men that work, mostly, she said. *Miners. A blacksmith. A man who keeps a store. They work all week and walk to chapel on Sunday and preach, and nobody pays them. They're quiet men. They're quiet when they walk and quiet when they stand. They look down when they pass you in the road, and they don't say much, and what they say you remember.*

What they do is decent, and what they say is gentle, and what they think, as near as I can tell, is clean. You'd not find a stain on Uncle Jabez if you turned him inside out. That's what my preachers are like.

Most folks are up when they're paid and down when they're not. My preachers aren't paid, so they're neither. When the mine shut down at Rough and Ready and there were no wages for a year, Uncle Jabez was the same on Sunday as he'd been when we were all eating meat.

Most folks are proud when they're well spoken of and sore when they're not. They called Uncle Jabez a fool in the Union, in print, for something he said about the saloons. He read it out at class meeting, the whole piece, and laughed, and went on to the next thing.

Most folks are glad when they're praised and sick when they're blamed. My preachers don't seem to hear either one. They're the same.

And most folks are glad when they're easy and miserable when they hurt. Uncle Jabez has the miner's con. He can't get a whole breath. I never heard him say so. That's what my preachers are like.

She said a good deal more. Grace Uglow sat with her hands in her lap and listened until the clock struck noon.

Could we see them? she said at last. *Could we see one of them here?*

I think we could.

Then do it, said Grace. *See to it.*

I will, Tamsin said.

V. Eight Handfuls

The tower · June 1892

SHE WAITED UNTIL THE SYRINGA BLOOMED.

It grew along the carriage drive below the tower, the old-fashioned white mock orange that smells like a sweeter jasmine, and in the second

week of June it came out all at once, so that the whole of Capitol Hill smelled of it in the evenings. She told the cook to lay in for a dinner of a hundred and to have it ready from the next noon on. Then in the long light of the evening she cut the syringa, armfuls of it, and carried it up the narrow stairs to the top of the tower, where there was a little railed walk around the roof.

From there you could see the whole of the Front Range, west across the city and the plains, with the snow still on it in June, white and pink in the last of the sun, a hundred miles of it from Pikes Peak to Longs. And beyond it, she knew, more mountains, and the desert, and the Sierra, and Grass Valley.

She faced west. She knelt on the tin roof, which was still warm from the day, and said the things she had been taught to say, and thought about Uncle Jabez for a long time, about his breathing and his hands and the way he stood at the front of the chapel waiting for people to finish coughing before he began. Then she stood up and took the syringa by handfuls and threw it into the air, toward the mountains, eight handfuls, one after another.

Uncle Jabez, she said, *I'm asking you to dinner tomorrow, you and all of them. Know by these that you're asked.*

The wind took the flowers. It took them up and west, over the city and the river and the plains and the mountains, and she stood on the tower and watched them go, white, then small, then gone.

• • •

In Grass Valley that same evening, an hour behind the Denver clock, it was class meeting at the chapel, and the windows were open for the heat. Uncle Jabez was sitting at the front with his Bible on his knee, the new Revised Version that John Trevenna had sent from San Francisco when it came out, and the others in a ring, miners and their wives, a blacksmith, a widow who kept boarders. He had just finished saying something short, and they were waiting to see if there was more.

The flowers came in at the windows. They came in a white stream, over the sills, over the heads of the people, and gathered themselves un-

der the ceiling over Uncle Jabez's chair and stayed there, turning slowly, a canopy of syringa a yard thick, not falling. The whole chapel smelled of it. A child laughed and was hushed. Nobody else made a sound.

John Trevenna was at the meeting. When it was done he went up to the front, under the flowers, with his hat in his hand, not looking up at them, and said, *Uncle Jabez, will you and the brothers come to my house for dinner tomorrow? I've a mind to give a dinner.*

Thank you, John. I'm asked already.

Asked? Who's asked you? There's nobody spoke to you before me. I was waiting by the door.

Tamsin asked me.

John stood there. *Tamsin's in Denver. That's a thousand mile.*

Uncle Jabez looked up then, at the flowers. He took a breath, as much as he could get, and let it go.

It is, he said. *The good show from a long way off, John, like the snow on the Sierra. You can see that from the top of Osborne Hill, and it's a long way off. And the other kind, you never see them at all. They're in the dark, shooting.* Then, because they were Methodists and wanted it from the Book, he opened the Revised Version on his knee and found the places, which he knew without looking, and read them out.

> *Ye are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hid.*
>
> *— Matthew 5:14 (Revised Version, 1881)*

> *For, lo, the wicked bend the bow, they make ready their arrow upon the string, that they may shoot in darkness at the upright in heart.*
>
> *— Psalm 11:2 (Revised Version, 1885)*

He closed the book. The flowers had begun, one at a time, to come down. They came down for a week. The chapel women swept them out every morning and every morning there were more.

VI. Five Hundred Roofs

Over the mountains · the next morning

Uncle Jabez chose five hundred men. He chose them by walking up Mill Street before sunup and down Main and out along the roads to the mines, stopping to get his breath, and putting his hand on a shoulder here and there. Men who had been sober the longest. Men who had never shorted a partner on a contract. Men who had sat up with the dying in the boarding houses and paid for the burying out of their own pay and never said whose. A good many of them were not Methodists. One was a Chinese cook from Boston Ravine who had been coming to class meeting in the back for two years without a word. One was Irish. Uncle Jabez did not seem to think it mattered.

And they went through the air.

That is how it is told in Grass Valley, and in Denver, and in Camborne, where it got to eventually by letter. Five hundred little houses with peaked roofs, like the cabins on the hills above the mines, one man in each, rose up off the flat at the foot of Mill Street at first light and went east together, over the Sierra and the snow, over the desert of Nevada and the salt and the Wasatch, over the Green River and the Laramie plains and the high peaks, and came down the long slope of the Front Range in the afternoon like a flight of geese.

Dick Uglow was on the tower. Tamsin had told him where to stand, and he had stood there since noon, in his shirtsleeves, with a pair of field glasses, telling himself he was a fool. He saw them come over the mountains. He went down the stairs of his tower two at a time, at fifty-one years old, and out of his front door and down the hill in the street, bareheaded, running, the way he had not run since he was a boy on the downs at Camborne, and he met the first of them as they came down in the road, and he took off the hat he did not have on, and stood there with his hand on his head.

He was not a man who did anything halfway. He put the five hundred up all over the Hill, in his house and his neighbors' houses and in the Brown Palace downtown, which had not yet opened its doors to anybody

and opened them to Cornish miners first. He fed them for seven days. He gave them every honor he knew how to give, which was a good many, and some that he made up. On the first night, after the dinner, he went and sat on the floor of his own library at the feet of a consumptive old tinner from Grass Valley, in his good trousers, like a boy at Sunday school, and asked him questions until two in the morning. Uncle Jabez answered them, briefly, between breaths.

On the fourth night Dick Uglow went up to the ballroom at the top of the house and turned up the gas as high as it would go, and stood there a while in the light looking at Madame Vesper's cabinet with the black curtains. Then he sent for a man to take it away.

More than Uglow listened. Before the week was out Grace Uglow had been to every meeting, and the cook, and the coachman, and the wives of the men who had laughed at Harry's Cornish wife, and a great many people on the Hill who had never in their lives been inside a Methodist chapel, and a great many people who were not from the Hill at all.

On the seventh day, when the five hundred went home the way they had come, Uncle Jabez put his hand on the shoulder of the youngest of them, Will Angove, who was twenty-two and could preach.

You stop here, Will, he said. *For Tamsin.*

Will stopped. He preached in Denver forty-one years.

VII. The Snow

Capitol Hill · 1893 and after

The next summer silver broke. The price went from eighty-three cents an ounce to sixty-two, and the mines at Leadville shut down and the smelters went cold, and the banks in Denver failed one after another, and men who had owned whole streets were selling their carriages in the newspaper. Dick Uglow lost the most of it. Not all; he had John Trevenna's mine in Grass Valley, which was gold. But the most.

They let the house on Capitol Hill go in 1895 and moved into a smaller one on Pearl Street, without a tower, with a little yard. Will Angove came

there to supper every Sunday. Harry went to work for a mining company as a clerk. Grace kept house herself, with one girl.

People who had known Dick Uglow in his silver days came to see how he was taking it. They were curious. They went away puzzled. He was the same, they said. He was easy. He was the same as he'd been before. He sat in his little yard in the evening in his shirtsleeves with his granddaughter on his knee and looked at the mountains, and when they asked him how he could bear it, he said that he had a daughter-in-law who had told him once what a man ought to be like, and he had been trying it for a year, and he found he liked it.

Tamsin outlived all of them. In her old age she kept the Revised Version that had belonged to Uncle Jabez, which Will Angove brought back from Grass Valley after the old man died in the winter of 1897 and had given to her because nobody had a better right. It had syringa in it. White petals, gone the color of tea, between the pages at the Sermon on the Mount and the eleventh Psalm, where the old man had pressed them on the night they came in at the chapel windows.

She would take it down sometimes in the evening and open it at those places and hold it to her face. Then she would go to the west window and look out at the Front Range, where the snow was, a hundred miles off, and plain to see.

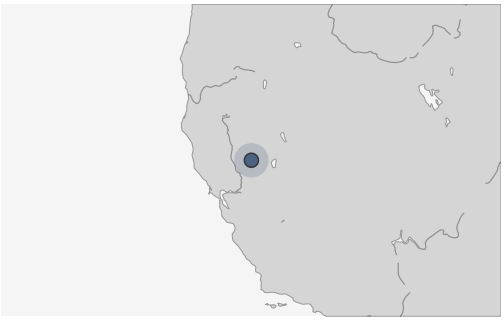
Background

The verse

> *Good people shine from afar, like the snowy mountains; bad people are not seen, like arrows shot by night.*
>
> Dhammapada 304, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the merchant Anāthapiṇḍika and his boyhood friend Ugga, who studied with the same teacher, promise each other their children in marriage. Years later Ugga visits Sāvatthī, is served so well by Anāthapiṇḍika's daughter Cullā Subhaddā that he asks for her for his son, and takes her far away to his own city, where his household honors naked ascetics. Out of modesty she refuses to pay them reverence; her father-in-law orders her out, but the eight sponsors her father sent

with her find her blameless. Her mother-in-law asks what her own teachers are like, and Subhaddā describes monks unmoved by gain and loss, fame and blame, praise and censure, pleasure and pain. Asked to bring them, she climbs to the top of the house and throws eight handfuls of jasmine into the air toward the Buddha, a hundred and twenty leagues away; the flowers form a canopy over him as he teaches, and he tells Anāthapiṇḍika that he is already invited. The next day the Buddha and five hundred monks travel through the air in gabled halls to Ugga's city, and the household is converted. Read the full commentary story, or about Anāthapiṇḍika.



Grass Valley, California, and Denver, Colorado

Grass Valley and Denver, 1892

When the copper and tin mines of Cornwall declined in the nineteenth century, Cornish miners carried their hard-rock skills, their pasties and their Methodism to mining camps across America. Grass Valley, in the Sierra foothills, was one of their strongholds, with the North Star, Empire and Idaho-Maryland gold mines, and it still keeps a Cornish Christmas and St. Piran's Day. More on Cornish Americans. Methodism ran on local preachers, laymen accredited to lead worship and preach while keeping their own trades. The Revised Version of the Bible, the first official revision of the King James text, appeared in 1881 (New Testament) and 1885 (Old Testament).

Silver from Leadville made Denver rich in the 1880s, and the money built mansions on Capitol Hill and the Brown Palace Hotel, which opened on August 12, 1892. Spiritualism had a following there too: in 1876 the *Rocky Mountain News* reported séances in a West Denver home with a curtained spirit cabinet and materialized "forms" (Colorado Newsline). In the Denver Depression of 1893 silver fell from 83 to 62 cents an ounce, banks collapsed and many lost their savings.

After the story of Cullā Subhaddā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 304). The original. Scripture from the English Revised Version (1881, 1885). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

21.9

Clean Bark

> *He shall sit solitary, and hold his peace: because he hath taken it up upon himself.*
> — *Lamentations 3:28*

Honela entzun nuen, at the long table on Main Street.

I. The End of the Table

Buffalo, Wyoming · winter 1963–64

At the Hotel Mendi on Main Street the herders ate at one long table, family style, the bowls going hand to hand down both sides: garbanzos with chorizo, oxtail stew, lamb, of course, always lamb, a pot of red beans, bread, wine in pitchers whether you asked for it or not. In winter, when the sheep were down on the lower range along the Powder River and the men came into town by turns, there might be thirty at that table on a Saturday night, talking across each other in Basque and Spanish and the bad English of the contract, laughing, singing after the coffee.

Fermín Arozena sat at the far end. Always the far end, where the table met the wall, and always with one empty chair between himself and the next man. He passed the bowls when they came to him. He answered when he was asked something, in a few words, politely. He did not sing. When he had eaten he carried his own plate to the kitchen, which nobody else did, and thanked the cook, and went up to his room, which was the single room at the end of the hall over the alley, the one with the narrow bed that the others didn't want.

In the morning he was gone before light. Joxe Etxeberri, who ran the bar downstairs and slept badly, would see him from the window going

down to Clear Creek alone in the dark with his hands in his coat, and coming back alone when the sky had gone grey over the Big Horns. At the eight o'clock Mass he sat in the last pew on the end. On Sunday afternoons, when the others crowded into the bar to hear the Basque program on KBBS, the news from home and the songs, Fermín was walking somewhere out on the bench above town by himself.

He was thirty-one. He was from a village in the Baztan valley in Navarre, and he had come over in 1962 on a three-year contract from the Western Range Association, like most of the young ones at the table, and he herded twelve hundred ewes for the Lindgren outfit. That was nearly all anybody knew about him.

II. The Mountain

The Big Horns · summer 1964

In June they trailed the bands up out of the sagebrush onto the national forest, eight days of dust and bells and dogs, and then every herder was alone. That was the work. A man, a band of sheep, two dogs, a horse, a canvas tent or a wagon, a hundred square miles of mountain. The camp tender came up once a week, with the pickup as far as the road went and then with a packhorse. He brought flour, coffee, beans, canned milk and the mail, and he moved camp when the grass was eaten down. For the rest of the week the herder spoke to the dogs.

Men did not do well with it. Everybody knew stories. A man from Bizkaia who had started answering the sheep in their own voice. A man who had walked down off the mountain one August without his band and was found in the stockyards in Billings with no shoes. Herders carved the aspens at the edges of the meadows: their names, the dates, the names of their villages, crosses, boats, hearts, women, verses about home and the girl and the mother who waited there. When you rode through an old grove you could read twenty years of loneliness on the white bark like the walls of a jail.

Txomin Laka was the camp tender for the Lindgren bands that summer. He had herded six years himself before he got the pickup, and he

knew what to look for. A man who talked too fast when you came. A man who did not talk at all. A man who had let himself go dirty, or whose dogs had gone wild. He watched all his herders for these things, the way you would watch a ewe that had stopped eating.

Fermín did not talk too fast. He did not talk much at all. But he was not dirty, and his dogs were the best-handled dogs on the mountain, and his sheep were fat. He lost fewer to coyotes and fewer to death camas than any herder Txomin had. When Txomin came up the trail with the packhorse, Fermín would already be standing at the tent, having heard him a mile off, with the coffee on. He would unload the flour and the beans. He would ask whether there were letters, and if there were, he would read them later, alone. He would say what the grass was like over the next ridge. Then he would go back up to the band, and Txomin would sit by the fire and drink the coffee by himself.

Once, late in the day, Txomin did not go straight back down. He tied the horse and went up through the timber on foot to see.

The band was bedded in the big meadow under the ridge, grey and quiet in the long light, and the dogs were lying at the two ends of it. Fermín was sitting at the top of the meadow where the aspens began, with his back against a white trunk, his hat on his knee, looking out over the sheep and the valley and the blue country beyond the Powder River that went on toward Dakota. He was not doing anything. He was sitting. He did not have a knife out. He did not have a letter. He did not have a bottle. Txomin watched him from the edge of the timber until the sun went off the meadow and the first star came out over the ridge, and Fermín did not move once, except to put his hat back on when it got cold.

On the way down Txomin rode through the aspens along the creek, where the old carvings were. There were names in that grove going back to 1919. There was a woman with long hair cut by somebody in 1937. There was a church with a bell tower and a date and the name of a village in Zuberoa. There were three Lindgren herders from the last two summers, their names and the dates and *Gora Euskadi* and a boat.

Up in Fermín's grove, Txomin realized, there was nothing. He had been taking him supplies all summer, past those trees, and not one of

them was cut. Clean bark, all of it. It frightened him more than anything else he had seen.

III. The Kitchen

The Hotel Mendi · October

Gracieuse Irigaray, who owned the Hotel Mendi, was seventy-two. She had come over from a village above Baigorri in 1912 to marry a herder she had met twice. She had cooked in a sheep camp in the Big Horns for three summers herself, in a wagon, before he saved enough to buy the hotel, and she had run it alone since he died in 1949. She had fed perhaps two thousand herders at that long table. She had read their letters to them when they couldn't and written their answers. She kept their money in the safe. She sat with them in the hospital, and she buried some of them. They called her Ama, every one of them, and she let them.

The sheep came down at the end of September. By the second week of October the bands were on the winter range, and the men were coming through town, and they all, one way or another, ended up in her kitchen saying the same thing.

Txomin told her first, standing by the stove with his hat in his hands. The empty chair. The clean bark. The man sitting at the edge of the trees until dark, not doing anything.

Then the cook told her about the plate he carried to the kitchen, and the room nobody wanted. Joxe from the bar told her about the creek before light. Two of the young herders told her that Fermín had walked past the dance at the Basque picnic in August without stopping, and that when they had asked him to drink with them on Main Street he had said no thank you, so nicely they could not even be angry. Mr. Lindgren himself came in, which he had not done in years, and sat at her kitchen table in his good hat. He said that Arozena was the best herder he had ever had, and that he was worried about him, and did she think the boy should see a doctor in Sheridan, and did she think he would sign on for another contract. Even Father Hanley, the young Irish priest, stopped her after

the eight o'clock Mass to ask, kindly, whether that quiet man in the back pew was all right.

She listened to every one of them. Then she said what she said to all of them, the same two words, in Basque, and went on with what she was doing.

Ondo, she said. *Ondo.* Good. Good.

Txomin did not understand. He came back the next day and stood by the stove again.

Ama, you didn't hear me. A man alone up there like that. With clean bark. You know what happens to them.

She was rolling dough on the board. She did not stop.

I know what happens to men who are alone and don't want to be, she said. *They carve the trees. They write home that they are coming home. They drink on Main Street until Joxe puts them out. That one wants to be. That is a different man.*

But all the time? Sitting alone, sleeping alone, walking alone?

That is how a herder should be, said Gracieuse Irigaray. *Alone, and taking care of himself. Somebody who keeps himself in hand like that can sit at the edge of the trees all evening and be happy. Didn't you see his face?*

Txomin thought about it. He had seen his face. He had not known what to call it.

She wiped her hands and went into the little parlor behind the kitchen and came back with a book, a small black English book with a cracked spine that the old Irish priest before Father Hanley had given her in 1920, when she was learning English, because it was the only English book he had two copies of. She found the page without looking for it and read it to him in her heavy careful English, standing by the bread board, while the dough rested.

> *Retirement, if thou continue therein, groweth sweet, but if thou keep not in it, begetteth weariness. If in the beginning of thy conversation thou dwell in it and keep it well, it shall afterwards be to thee a dear friend, and a most pleasant solace.*
>
> *— Thomas à Kempis, The Imitation of Christ, I.20 (tr. William Benham)*

He kept it well, she said. *Go and tell the others.*

Then she went back to the dough.

IV. The Edge of the Trees

Buffalo and the Big Horns · 1965 and after

TXOMIN TOLD THE OTHERS, AND THEY TOLD EACH OTHER AT the long table, in the bar, and in the sheep camps the next summer. It went around the way things went around among the Basques of that country, which is to say everywhere at once and slowly. Ama had said *ondo.* Ama had read the little book.

Nobody could say afterward that anything much changed. But that next summer on the mountain there were herders who did not go down to Buffalo for the Fourth. There were men who sat at the tops of their meadows in the evening with their hats on their knees and did not take out their knives. Txomin noticed that some of the young ones he had worried about the summer before talked less fast when he came. Two of them asked him for the bands farthest out. One of them, a boy from Bizkaia who had carved his girlfriend's name in fourteen trees the year before, carved nothing at all.

Fermín signed on for a second contract, and then a third. He never married. When the Basque herders were mostly gone, in the seventies, when the young men stayed home in the factories of Navarre and Bizkaia and the outfits started bringing herders up from Peru instead, he stayed on in Wyoming and herded for the Lindgren grandsons until his knees gave out. He lived his last years in the single room at the end of the hall at the Hotel Mendi, after Gracieuse was gone and her granddaughter ran

it. He still ate at the far end of the table. He still walked down to Clear Creek before light.

• • •

Most of the old groves on that mountain have fallen now, or burned, or been cut. Aspens do not live much past a hundred years, and the carved ones die sooner, from the wounds. A few still stand along the creek below the big meadow, and people from town go up some summers to photograph them before they go: the names, the dates, the villages, the women with long hair, the boats, the crosses, *Gora Euskadi*, the verses about coming home.

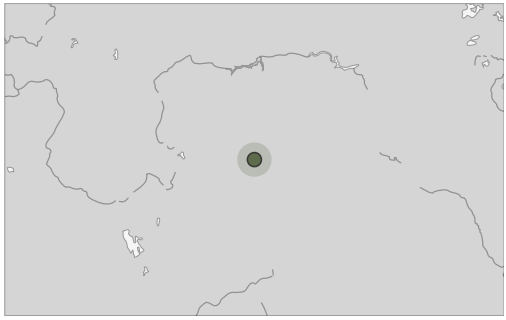
At the top of the meadow, where the aspens begin, there is one trunk with no writing on it at all. It is the oldest tree in that stand. The bark is clean and white from the ground to the first branches, except for one place about the height of a seated man's shoulders, on the side that faces the valley, where it has been worn smooth and a little grey by something that leaned against it, evening after evening, for a great many years.

Background

The verse

> *He alone who, without ceasing, practises the duty of sitting alone and sleeping alone, he, subduing himself, will rejoice in the destruction of all desires alone, as if living in a forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 305, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is among the shortest in the collection. An elder known to the whole fourfold community of monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen sat alone, walked alone and stood alone, and was called Ekavihārī, "the one who dwells alone." The monks told the Buddha about his way of life, and the Buddha, instead of correcting him, exclaimed "Well done! Well done!" and praised the solitary life in this verse. After that, many people wished to live alone. Read the full commentary story, or about the Dhammapada itself.



Buffalo, Wyoming

Basque herders in Wyoming, 1964

Basques had been in Buffalo, at the foot of the Big Horn Mountains, since at least 1902, and the town became one of the centers of Basque life in the Mountain West. A local radio station, KBBS, broadcast a weekly Basque-language program from 1956 to 2000. After the Second World War a shortage of herders led Congress to pass special "sheepherder laws," and from 1950 to the mid-1970s the sheepmen's Western Range Association brought several thousand Basques, mostly from Spain, to the West on three-year contracts. Herding was among the loneliest jobs in the country: a man spent the summer alone in the mountains with a band of sheep, a dog or two and a horse, supplied once a week by a camp tender. In town, the Basque boarding-house was the herders' home, and its keeper often served as their interpreter, postmaster and adviser. As wages rose in the Basque Country, the flow stopped, and by the mid-1970s fewer than a hundred Basque herders remained in the American West.

Across the West, herders left their marks on the bark of aspen groves: names, dates and hometowns, crosses, boats from fishing villages, women, the political slogan *Gora Euskadi* ("Long live the Basque Country"), and verses of longing for home. About 25,000 of these arborglyphs have been documented, and they are disappearing as the trees die. The Hotel Mendi, its people and the Lindgren outfit are fictional.

After the story of the Elder Ekavihārī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 305). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible and from Thomas à Kempis, *The Imitation of Christ*, translated by William Benham. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 22

The Downward Course

22.1

The Deed Reading

Be sure your sin will find you out.
— Numbers 32:23

I heard it like this, in Boley.

I. The Porch

Boley, Okfuskee County, Oklahoma · summer 1913

Isaac Grayson read papers for nothing. That was the whole of it, at first.

He had hung out his shingle on Main Street in the fall of 1911, a narrow frame office between the barbershop and the Farmers' Gin, with a back room where he slept on a cot. He was twenty-seven. His grandmother had been owned by a Creek family on the Arkansas River before the war, and after the war she was a Creek citizen with a Creek name, and when the Dawes men came with their books, Isaac and every one of his brothers and sisters had been enrolled as Creek Freedmen and allotted a hundred and sixty acres apiece. He had sold forty of his own to go to school. He had read law in a white lawyer's office in Muskogee, sweeping it out in the mornings, and passed the bar on the second try, and come home.

He did not talk much. People said he talked in the courtroom like a Baptist preacher and everywhere else like a man who was paying for every word by the pound.

In the evenings, when the heat let go a little, he carried his lamp and a kitchen chair out onto the porch of the office and sat there, and anybody who had a paper could bring it. A lease. A deed. A guardian's report from the county court. A letter from a man in Tulsa who wanted to buy your

mineral rights for a dollar an acre. He would hold the paper to the lamp and read it to you, every word, out loud, and tell you what it said, and then tell you what it meant, which was usually something else. He did not charge a nickel. When people asked him why, he said, *It's your land.*

That was all. But by the summer of 1913 the line on his porch went down the steps and along the board sidewalk past the barbershop most nights, farmers in from the bottoms still in their overalls, widows, young men who had just turned twenty-one and come into what was left of their allotments, old Creek-speaking men and women who had been born in the Nation before there was any Oklahoma, standing in the dusk waiting their turn, talking low, fanning themselves with their papers.

And people stopped signing things.

That was the trouble. Boley was the finest town of colored people in the world, the paper said so every week. It had two banks and three gins and an ice plant and its own electric light, and two colleges, and a brand-new Masonic Temple, the tallest building between Okmulgee and Oklahoma City, people said. Booker T. Washington had come and made a speech. But Boley sat in the middle of a great deal of land that belonged to Creek Freedmen, and in 1908 Congress had taken the restrictions off Freedman land, so that it could be sold or leased or mortgaged like anybody's, and then they found oil at Cushing, and since then a man who knew how to get an old woman's mark on the right line of the right paper could do very well indeed.

II. The Land Men

Pettiford's Real Estate & Loan, Main Street · August

Cyrus Pettiford had done very well indeed. He was a notary public and an agent for two lease companies in Okmulgee and a broker of farm loans, and he had sat in the front pew of the Baptist church for six years, and the county judge at Okemah had made him guardian of the allotments of eleven minor children, whose rents he collected and whose reports he filed, and nobody had ever in six years read one of those reports out loud. His partner was Lyle Ransom, who wrote

LETTERS FOR PEOPLE WHO COULD NOT WRITE, AND READ THEM their letters back for a dime, and had a way of reading a letter from a lease company so that it said what Pettiford needed it to say.

They were not having a good summer. Since spring Pettiford had not closed one lease worth closing. Widows who had signed whatever he put in front of them for six years were coming into his office, sitting down, folding their hands, and saying, *I believe I'll take that home and study on it.* Which meant they would take it to the porch. Two of his wards' mothers had gone to the county court about the rents. Lyle Ransom had not read a letter for anybody since June. Men who used to tip their hats to Pettiford in the street now said *Evening* and kept walking, and some nights you could stand at Pettiford's window and look down Main Street and see the lamp on Grayson's porch and the line going down the steps and nobody at all on yours.

He's got this whole town reading, Ransom said.

He's got this whole town thinking it's smarter than the men who built it, said Pettiford. *Who can we use?*

They thought of Ora Lee Waters at about the same moment.

She was nineteen and the best-looking girl in Okfuskee County, everybody said so, tall and dark and quick, with a laugh you could hear across the street. Her mother was a Creek Freedwoman from out by Castle and her father was dead. Ora Lee had been one of Pettiford's wards until her eighteenth birthday, when the law said a girl came of age, and she had come into her hundred and sixty acres and found there was a mortgage on it with her own mark at the bottom, from when she was sixteen, that she did not remember making. She owed Pettiford three hundred and ten dollars. She sang in the choir. She also went to the Saturday night dances out on the river road, which the choir did not know about, and Pettiford did.

She came into the office the next afternoon to pay her interest. Pettiford wrote the receipt and did not say a word to her. Ransom sat in the corner with his newspaper and did not look up.

Mr. Pettiford, did I do something to you?

Nothing.

Mr. Pettiford. Somebody done you wrong?

He put the pen down. *Ora Lee, look out that window. You see that lamp? That man is taking the bread out of my mouth and yours. He's turning this town against the men who built it. Every lease I lose is money that should have come to this town.*

What do you want me to do about it?

You're a good-looking girl, said Pettiford. *Folks talk about a good-looking girl. Give them something to talk about. And that paper on your land,* he said, and took it out of the drawer and laid it on the desk between them, *that paper could get lost.*

Ora Lee looked at the paper a long time. Then she said, *All right.*

III. The Flowers

Main Street · August and September

EVERY EVENING AFTER THAT, WHEN THE LAMP WENT OUT ON the porch and the last of the line was walking home, Ora Lee Waters came down Main Street the other way, toward the gin, in her Sunday dress. She carried a fruit jar of zinnias from her mother's yard, and a bottle of bay rum from the drugstore, and a paper sack of oranges from the depot, and she walked slow, past the barbershop where the men sat out on the bench, past the pool hall, past the women on the porches.

Where you going this late, Ora Lee?

Going to sit up with the lawyer, she said. *I sit up with him most every night.*

She went around behind the gin in the dark and through the cotton wagons and out the other side to Lyle Ransom's sister's house, and slept there. In the morning she came back up Main Street the same way, slow, with her hair half down, and when the women at the pump asked her where she had been all night she yawned and said, *Where you think? I been with Lawyer Grayson. He don't let a girl get much sleep.* And she laughed her laugh that you could hear across the street.

Every morning Isaac Grayson found a jar of zinnias on his front step, or a bottle of bay rum, or oranges, and did not know where they came from, and did not ask, and carried them around back and threw them on

the heap behind the gin where the gin threw its trash, burrs and lint and broken bale ties and dirt, so that by September there was a slope of withered zinnias down one side of the heap, red and orange and dried to paper.

Only once did she come to the porch in daylight. It was a hot evening at the end of September, and she stood in the line like anybody, behind a farmer from the bottoms and in front of two old women from Clearview, with her hands empty, and when her turn came she sat down in the kitchen chair across from him under the lamp. The people in the line went very quiet. She had never been that close to him. He was younger than she had thought, and tired, with ink on his second finger.

You don't have a paper, he said.

No. She looked at the lamp and not at him. *Say a girl had a paper. Say there was a mark on it she don't remember making. What would you read her?*

Whatever it said.

Could a paper like that be wrong?

Papers are wrong all the time, said Isaac Grayson. *Bring it and see.*

She sat a moment longer with her hands in her lap. Then she laughed, the laugh you could hear across the street, and got up and went off down the sidewalk, and that night the jar of zinnias was on his step as usual.

The talk went the way talk goes. Some people did not believe it. Most people did not want to, and believed it anyway. A few of the widows stopped coming to the porch. A deacon came by and stood in the door of the office with his hat on and said there were some things a church could not have, and went away without waiting for an answer. Pettiford closed two leases in September.

Then, on the second Saturday of October, he paid two men from the Cushing field forty dollars apiece.

IV. The Heap

Behind the Farmers' Gin · October

On Monday morning Cyrus Pettiford walked into the town marshal's office with his hat in his hand and his face drawn down long, and Lyle Ransom behind him.

Marshal, Ora Lee Waters ain't come home. Her mother's out of her mind. Since Saturday night.

Who'd she go with?

Pettiford looked at the floor like a man who does not want to say a thing. *Marshal, you know where she's been going nights. The whole town knows. What happened to her there, I couldn't say.*

The marshal was a big quiet man named Hollis Lee who had been a sergeant in the Tenth Cavalry and did not like Pettiford and did not like Grayson much either, because he did not like lawyers. He looked at Pettiford a while.

Then go look, he said.

They went to look. They took a dozen men with them, men from Pettiford's church and Ransom's lodge, and they went straight down Main Street to the gin, and around behind it, and Pettiford stood back with his hands folded while the others poked at the heap with cotton hooks, and it was Ransom who called out.

She was lying in the zinnias. Somebody had hit her once on the side of the head and thrown her up on the heap like a sack, and she had rolled a little way down the slope of dead flowers, and her Sunday dress was spread out on them, and there were burrs in her hair.

They took the door off the gin office and carried her on it up the middle of Main Street, eight men, at noon, with the whole town coming out of the stores. Pettiford walked in front. When they came opposite the lawyer's office he stopped them and turned around to the crowd, and said it loud.

Look here. Look what they did. That man and his people. He couldn't have it known what he'd been doing nights, so they put her out of the way and threw her on his trash. Look at her. Look at her, Boley.

Isaac Grayson stood in his doorway and looked. He did not say anything at all.

The marshal had the door set on two sawhorses on the steps of the Masonic Temple, in the shade, with a sheet over it and two men to watch, and sent a boy on a mule for the girl's mother, and then he went into his office and shut the door and sat a long time with his head in his hands. Everybody in Boley knew what he was thinking about. Two years before, a colored woman and her boy had been taken out of the county jail at Okemah at midnight and hanged from the bridge over the North Canadian, and in the morning hundreds of white people had come out to look, and a man had made photographs. If the county got hold of this, a dead girl and a colored lawyer and a story like this one, nobody knew what the county would do. Not to the lawyer. To the town.

V. What Shall Be Said

Boley · that week

By dark the whole town had it. By the next day the whole county. Pettiford's people went from porch to porch, and to the barbershop, and the gins, and the two colleges, and out into the bottoms on horseback, saying it. *See what they did. See what the lawyer's people did.* The ones who believed it said it to the ones who didn't, and after a while the ones who didn't stopped saying anything.

It fell on the people who had stood in the line. Not on Isaac. On them. A widow who had taken her lease to the porch had a cup of coffee thrown on her in the bank. A young man who had been read his own guardian's report out loud, and had gone to the county court about it, was knocked down outside the pool hall by two of Pettiford's lodge brothers and kicked. Old Aunt Sukey Grant, who had been born in the Creek Nation in 1838 and could not read one word, was spat at on the board sidewalk by a girl of fourteen. Children chanted it in the schoolyard. The people from the line stopped going to the post office. They stopped going to church.

On the Wednesday night seven or eight of them came to the back door of the office, because they did not dare come to the front any more, and stood in the back room among the law books, and asked him what they should do. Should they go to the county? Should they get guns? Should they leave? Some of them were crying.

Isaac Grayson had not said twenty words since Monday. He sat on the edge of his cot with his elbows on his knees.

Don't fight anybody, he said. *Don't argue. Don't explain. You weren't there and you don't know, and neither do they. When they say it to you, you say this back to them. Only this. Then walk on.*

And he said it to them, twice, so they would have it, the way he would read them a paper.

> *A false witness shall not be unpunished, and he that speaketh lies shall perish.*
>
> *— Proverbs 19:9*
>
> *But if ye will not do so, behold, ye have sinned against the LORD: and be sure your sin will find you out.*
>
> *— Numbers 32:23*

They did it. That was the thing people remembered afterward, even people who had chanted in the schoolyard. When the widow in the bank was called a whore's friend to her face, she said, *He that speaketh lies shall perish,* and finished her business and walked out. When the boys outside the pool hall started on old Aunt Sukey Grant again, she stopped on the sidewalk with her cane and turned around, and said in her old Creek-country voice, slow, so they would hear every word, *Be sure your sin will find you out,* and the boys went quiet and went inside. It was not much. It was a few words, and everybody in Boley already knew them. But you could not fight it and you could not argue with it, and after a few days, people who said the thing on the sidewalk began to hear those words before they had even finished saying it, and some of them stopped saying it.

VI. Choc Beer

The bottoms below Boley · Saturday night

The marshal had not been idle. On the Tuesday he had sent for his deputy, a young man named Elias Moore who had been raised in the bottoms and knew every still and choc joint between Boley and the Canadian, and told him, *Go find out if anybody else did this.*

Oklahoma had been dry since statehood. That did not stop anybody. Down in the river bottoms below town there was a woman named Mattie who brewed choc beer in a washtub out of barley and hops and anything else that would work, the beer people called Choctaw beer from the old Territory days, and sold it out of her kitchen on Saturday nights by the dipper, and the oil field men came over from the Cushing field on payday because in Boley nobody looked twice at a colored man with money.

Two of them were there that Saturday. They had been there the Saturday before, too, and had been spending free. Elias Moore sat in the corner of Mattie's kitchen with a dipper he did not drink from and listened to them get drunk.

It took till midnight. Then the bigger one wanted the other one to pay for the round, and the other one said he had paid for the last three, and the bigger one said something about who had done the work, and the other one stood up and knocked his chair over.

Who did the work? Who did the work? You hit her one time, one time, and throwed her up on the lawyer's flowers, and you been drinking her forty dollars for a week, and you ask me who did the work?

The kitchen went quiet. Mattie put down her dipper.

Hush, said the bigger one. *You hush. Let it be. Let it be.*

Elias Moore stood up in the corner with his pistol out and said, *No. I don't believe we'll let it be.*

VII. The Temple Steps

Boley · Monday

THE TWO MEN TOLD IT ALL IN THE MARSHAL'S OFFICE BEFORE daylight on Sunday. The forty dollars apiece. Who paid it. The pick handle. The heap. They had not even known her name.

On Monday morning Hollis Lee walked down Main Street with Elias Moore beside him and a shotgun under his arm and went into Pettiford's Real Estate & Loan and came out with Cyrus Pettiford, and then went three doors down and came out with Lyle Ransom, and walked them both up the middle of the street to the steps of the Masonic Temple, where the girl had lain under the sheet all week until her mother took her home to Castle to bury her. By then the whole town was following.

He did not take them to Okemah. Not yet. He stood them on the Temple steps in front of everybody in Boley, and the mayor came out of the bank and stood beside him, and the marshal said, not loud, the way a sergeant says a thing he is only going to say once:

You carried her up this street and told them who did it. Now you tell them.

Pettiford looked at the crowd. He was a man who had talked his way out of a great many things. He opened his mouth, and the first thing that came out of the crowd at him, before he could say a word, was an old woman's voice from down in front, slow, in a Creek-country accent.

Be sure your sin will find you out.

Then somebody else said it. Then a great many people, not loud, not all together, the widows and the farmers and the young men from the line, and some of the very ones who had said the other thing all week, until it was going through the crowd on Main Street like a wind going through cotton.

Pettiford said it. He said they had paid the men. He said they had done it to bring disgrace on Lawyer Grayson because he was ruining their business. He said there was no fault in Grayson, that Grayson had never laid eyes on the girl at night in his life, and that none of the people from the line had any part in it. The marshal made him say it twice, so the back of the crowd could hear. Then Ransom said it. Then the marshal put

them in a wagon and drove them to the county jail at Okemah himself, with the shotgun across his knees, and at the trial in the spring they got life at McAlester, all four.

• • •

The lamp was back on the porch the next evening. The line went down the steps and along the board sidewalk past the barbershop and the pool hall and around the corner, longer than it had ever been, and the people in it stood in the dusk with their papers and did not talk much.

The last one in line, near ten o'clock, was a woman from out by Castle in a black dress, with a paper folded small in her hand. She did not sit in the chair. She held the paper out to him and he took it and unfolded it under the lamp. It was a patent from the Creek Nation, signed by the Principal Chief, for a hundred and sixty acres, and pinned to the back of it was the mortgage, which the marshal had found in Pettiford's desk.

That's hers, the woman said. *Read it to me.*

Isaac Grayson unpinned the mortgage and laid it face down on the porch boards, and held the patent up to the light, and read it to her slowly, every word, the way he read everybody's, down to the description of the land: the quarter section, the township, the range, the creek that ran along the south line of it. And the name that was written in at the top, which was Ora Lee Waters, and still was.

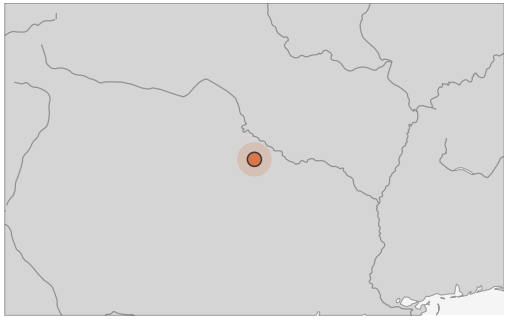
Background

The verse

> *He who says what is not, goes to hell; he also who, having done a thing, says I have not done it. After death both are equal, they are men with evil deeds in the next world.*
>
> Dhammapada 306, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, rival ascetics who have lost their followers and their gifts to the Buddha persuade a beautiful wandering nun, Sundarī, to ruin his name. Every evening she walks toward his monastery with garlands and perfumes, telling people she

spends her nights with him, and every morning she walks back the same way. After some days the rivals pay men to kill her and throw her body on the heap of withered garlands near the Buddha's chamber, then report her missing to the king, lead the search, carry her body through the city, and cry out that the monks have murdered her to hide their teacher's sin. The whole city turns on the monks. The Buddha tells them only to answer with a verse about liars and deniers. The king's men find the killers quarrelling drunk over their pay, and the king makes the rivals go through the city proclaiming their own guilt and the Buddha's innocence. The same tale is told in the Udāna and the Jātaka. Read the full commentary story.



Boley, Oklahoma

Boley, 1913

Boley opened for settlement in 1903 on the allotment of Abigail Barnett, daughter of a Creek Freedman, and was incorporated in 1905. By 1911, the Oklahoma Historical Society records, it had more than four thousand people, two banks, three cotton gins, an electric plant, an ice plant and two colleges, and Booker T. Washington had visited and praised it; its Masonic Temple, finished around 1912, was said to be the tallest building between Okmulgee and Oklahoma City. The Freedmen of the Creek Nation, descendants of people the Creeks had enslaved, had been made Creek citizens by treaty and were allotted land on the Dawes Rolls. In 1908 Congress lifted all restrictions on the sale of Freedman land, adults' and minors' alike, and put minors' land under the county probate courts, where guardians could be appointed to manage it. The discovery of the Cushing oil field in 1912 made such land, and the papers that controlled it, far more valuable.

Oklahoma entered the Union dry in 1907, and home-brewed choc beer was sold on the quiet for decades. Boley was also a town that lived with fear. In May 1911 a crowd of white men took Laura Nelson and her son from the county jail at Okemah and hanged them from a bridge over the North Canadian River; hundreds came out to look, and the town photographer made pictures. Historians have read the photographs as a warning meant for Boley, and rumors that Boley men would retaliate set

Okemah's men guarding Main Street. More on the lynching of Laura and L. D. Nelson.

After the story of the wanderer Sundarī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 306). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.2

Rose Sunday

> *… and others which, Sabbath after Sabbath, looked devoutly heavenward, and benignantly over the crowded pews, from the holiest pulpits in the land.*
> *— Nathaniel Hawthorne, "Young Goodman Brown"*

This is the way I heard it, on Ashmont Street.

I. Father Rafferty

Dorchester, Boston · 1959–2002

For thirty-five years Frank Dineen drew a priest. The strip was called Father Rafferty, four panels a week, and it ran in diocesan papers from Boston to Sacramento between 1959 and 1994. Father Rafferty was a curate in a city parish with a bad knee and a worse car. He lost at checkers to the altar boys. He hid from the pastor in the confessional to eat his lunch. He had a round face and a cowlick, and Frank drew around his head, whenever he was doing something kind, five or six short pen lines, the way you draw a lamp to show that it is lit. Readers wrote in about the lines. Nuns cut the strip out and pinned it to bulletin boards. Frank drew it at a slant-top table in the attic of a three-decker on Ashmont Street, and for the first eleven years the model for Father Rafferty's face was whichever curate was newest at St. Ita's down the hill.

He retired the strip when his hand began to shake, and after his wife died he kept on drawing for himself, people on the Red Line, his neighbors, the gulls at Malibu Beach. He had a way of seeing a face. His wife used to say he could look at a man across a wake and tell you what the man's mother had looked like.

In January of 2002 the Globe began to print what it had found, and it did not stop all year. By the fall there were court files on the kitchen tables of Dorchester, and names in them that people had been baptized and married by. Frank found that he could not draw a priest. He tried in the spring, with his nephew. Kevin Dineen was ordained in May, at twenty-seven, one of a small class, in the worst year anyone could remember to be a young man in a Roman collar on the Red Line, and Frank sat down to draw him as a gift and put the pen down after the cowlick. He could not get the face to hold still. It kept turning into somebody else's.

Kevin was sent to St. Ita's in June. Nora Healy was still the sacristan there. She had been the sacristan since 1951.

II. Parker Hill

Mission Hill · Saturday, December 14

On the Saturday after the cardinal resigned they buried Frank's old friend Tom Grealish from the Mission Church on Tremont Street, the big gray basilica with the two spires on the side of Parker Hill. Kevin concelebrated. Afterward, because it was a dry cold afternoon and Frank wanted the air, the two of them walked down through the streets below the hill toward the Orange Line, Kevin in his black overcoat and collar, Frank in his good hat. People looked at the collar. One man on a stoop said something, and Kevin nodded to him as if he had said good afternoon.

It was nearly dark. The sun had gone down behind the hill and the sky over the city was green going to blue. They had come to the corner of Tremont and were waiting for the light when Frank stopped talking.

Kevin looked at him and then looked where he was looking, up over the roofs, and saw nothing. A plane coming into Logan. The first stars.

Frank was smiling. It was not a big smile. It was the smile Kevin had seen on him at the drafting table when a face finally came right, a small private one, at one side of the mouth.

Uncle Frank. What is it?

Not here, said Frank. *Ask me at Nora's. Ask me in front of Nora.*

He did not say anything else all the way home on the train.

III. The Sacristy

St. Ita's, Dorchester · Sunday, December 15

The next morning was the third Sunday of Advent, Gaudete Sunday, when the purple of the season lets up for a day and the priest wears rose. Nora Healy had the rose vestments out on the long counter in the sacristy at seven, the chasuble on its padded hanger, the stole, the alb pressed the night before, the amice folded square, the cincture coiled in a flat white spiral like a rope on the deck of a boat. She was eighty. She had ironed for every priest in that house for fifty-one years, and three women from the altar guild who were not much younger were with her, folding purificators at the table under the window. Frank came in with Kevin at a quarter past seven and sat on the radiator in his coat.

Kevin started to vest. He put the amice on his shoulders and tied the strings, and then he stopped.

Ask him, said Nora, without turning around. She had been watching them since they came in.

Yesterday on Tremont Street, Kevin said. *He smiled at something. Up over the roofs. I asked him what it was and he said to ask him in front of you.*

The women at the table had stopped folding.

Frank took off his hat.

Six priests, he said. *Going over the city at about the height of the steeple, toward the harbor. The first one in front and five behind him. They were vested for Mass, the way you vest them, Nora, alb and stole and chasuble, and every bit of it was on fire. The cinctures were burning like fuses. They had their chalices in their hands, and the chalices were on fire. And there was nothing inside the vestments. There was the shape of a man, and the fire went right through him, and you could see the bones.*

Nobody said anything.

I knew the faces, Frank said. *I drew two of them.*

And you smiled, said Kevin.

For thirty-five years I put lines around their heads, Frank said. *Last night they looked like themselves.*

Nora Healy came around the end of the counter and sat down on the vesting stool, which no one had ever seen her do.

I'll tell you who they were, she said, *and then I won't say it again.*

She told them about the old days in that house, when there were four priests in the rectory and a Mass every hour on Sunday morning and boys waiting in line in cassocks to serve. She did not tell them anything that was not already in the newspapers, and she did not say the names, and everyone in that sacristy knew the names. She told them about a boy who came out of the rectory one evening in 1964 and sat on the curb by the sacristy door and would not tell her what was wrong, and how she had gone to the pastor, and the pastor had told her that her business was the linens. She said she had minded the linens for thirty-eight years after that. She said she had washed their albs and starched them and coiled their cinctures, and polished their chalices on Saturday nights, and that one of the six chalices was still in the safe behind her, where its owner had left it in 1979 when he was moved, and that she had not let it be used since.

Many, she said. *I'm not saying all. I'm saying many. They wore it at the neck and it meant nothing to them. And they went where those deeds were going to take them. They were always going there. Frank just saw them on the way.*

Then she said that Sister Gertrude had made them read a story in the eleventh grade at the Academy, in 1938, about a young man in Salem who goes into the woods one night and finds the whole church there in the firelight, the ministers and the deacons and the good women, and that she had never forgotten one sentence of it, and she said it:

> *Among them, quivering to and fro between gloom and splendor, appeared faces that would be seen next day at the council board of the province, and others which, Sabbath after Sabbath, looked devoutly heavenward, and benignantly over the crowded pews, from the holiest pulpits in the land.*
>
> *— Nathaniel Hawthorne, "Young Goodman Brown," Mosses from an Old Manse (1846)*

And then Sister made us read to the end, Nora said, *which is the part I want you to hear, Father. He never trusted anybody again after that night, the young man. Not his wife, not his minister, not one soul. He went to his grave like that. That's the other way to go to hell. I'm not having it in this house.*

She got up off the stool.

You're late, she said to Kevin. *Arms up.*

He put his arms up and she dropped the alb over him and pulled it straight at the shoulders, and handed him the cincture, and he tied it. She laid the stole across his neck. The three women at the table had not gone back to the purificators. One of them, Mrs. Coughlin, had a grandson who had served in that sacristy in the sixties and had never come back to Mass, and she was crying without any noise, and folding, and not looking at anybody. The second one had put her hand flat on the table. The third, the youngest, who was seventy-three, got up and went into the church and knelt in the front pew with her coat on, and did not come back until the bell.

Kevin stood in his rose vestments in the middle of the sacristy. He was twenty-seven years old. He looked down at the cincture knotted at his waist, and then at the safe, and then at Nora.

All right, he said.

IV. Rose

St. Ita's · the same morning

FRANK STAYED ON THE RADIATOR THROUGH THE EIGHT o'clock. He could see a slice of the sanctuary through the sacristy door,

Kevin at the altar in rose, which on a young man in that light looks almost white, the color of the inside of a shell. Mrs. Coughlin's grandson was not there. The church was a third full, which in December of 2002 was a good Sunday.

There was a pad of Mass cards by the sacristy phone. Frank took one, and the ballpoint pen on its chain, and turned the card over and drew Kevin from where he sat, in profile, lifting the host at the consecration, the chasuble falling from his raised arms, the cowlick standing up at the back. It took him about a minute. His hand did not shake.

When he was done he looked at it a long time. Then he left it on the counter by the rose stole's empty hanger, face up, for Nora, with no lines around the head.

Background

The verse

> *Many men whose shoulders are covered with the yellow gown are ill-conditioned and unrestrained; such evil-doers by their evil deeds go to hell.*
>
> Dhammapada 307, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Mahā Moggallāna, known for his psychic powers, is coming down from Vulture's Peak with the elder Lakkhaṇa when he sees hungry ghosts (petas) in the form of skeletons, and smiles. Lakkhaṇa asks why. This is not the time, Moggallāna says; ask me in the presence of the Teacher. Before the Buddha he tells what he saw: a monk flying through the air with his body on fire, and five companions behind him, their bowls, robes and girdles all burning. The Buddha explains that these were monks who had gone forth under an earlier Buddha, Kassapa, and had not lived by what they took on, and he speaks the verse to the monks sitting before him; many of them reach the first stage of awakening. The Pāli verse speaks of those with the ochre robe "around the neck." Read the full commentary story. Nora's sentence is from Nathaniel Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown", first published in 1835 and collected in *Mosses from an Old Manse* (1846); the story ends with Brown living out his life in suspicion of everyone he knows.

Mission Hill and Dorchester, Boston, Massachusetts

Boston, 2002

In January 2002 the *Boston Globe*'s Spotlight team began publishing its investigation of how the Archdiocese of Boston had handled priests who abused children, beginning with John Geoghan, who was accused of abusing more than 130 children and had been moved from parish to parish. The coverage ran all year. It led to criminal prosecutions, hundreds of civil suits and, in 2003, a Pulitzer Prize for Public Service; in 2011 the archdiocese published a list of 159 priests credibly accused. See the sexual abuse scandal in the Boston archdiocese.

In early December the archdiocese released thousands of pages of personnel files under court order. On December 9, fifty-eight Boston priests signed a letter asking Cardinal Bernard Law to resign, and on Friday, December 13, he resigned, as *America* reported. Two days later came the third Sunday of Advent, called Gaudete or Rose Sunday, when the priest may wear rose instead of violet. The Mission Church, the Redemptorists' basilica on Parker Hill in Mission Hill, was dedicated in 1878. St. Ita's and its people are fictional.

After the story of the fruits and powers of bad conduct from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 307). The original. Words of Nathaniel Hawthorne from "Young Goodman Brown," *Mosses from an Old Manse* (1846). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.3

The Hitch Ball

> *Bread of falsehood is sweet to a man; But afterwards his mouth shall be filled with gravel.*
> *— Proverbs 20:17*

Well, the way I heard it, at the Cenex in Vang.

I. The Placement

Swift County, Minnesota · June 1987

The corn was good that year, and it did not matter. It was knee-high well before the Fourth and the color of a pool table, and a bushel of it was worth about a dollar and a half. Land that had brought eleven hundred dollars an acre five years before brought seven hundred if it brought anything. There were men in the county with ten thousand bushels in the bin and a wife who drove to the food shelf in Benson on Thursdays, in the next town over's car if she could borrow it, so the neighbors would not know the plates.

Reuben Lindquist had cried farm sales in six counties for forty years. Everybody called him Colonel, as they called every auctioneer. In the spring of 1984 he sold out the son of a man he had sold out in 1934, put his cane and his hat in the closet, and never took a sale bill again. He was seventy-six now, a widower with eighty acres rented out, and what he did was run the Harvest Workers.

It was a small thing and it was his own. Winters, twenty or so young people sat in the old creamery at Vang and he took them through the Bible a book at a time. Summers he put them out in twos and fours with country congregations that had lost their pastor or could not pay one, from the first of June until the corn was in. They taught the children's

Bible school, held a meeting Sunday night, and slept where they were given a bed. He paid them nothing. He told them each year the one thing he told them. *You eat what they eat.*

For a man who had talked two hundred words a minute for a living, he did not say much. People who had heard him on the block found it hard to credit.

That June he put four of them at the Skog church, eleven miles north of Vang, in the township that had seen the most sales. Todd Engen and Curt Maas were twenty-two, Lori Pauling was twenty, and Peg Rasmussen was nineteen. They had been friends since their first winter in the creamery. He drove them up himself, and on the way he pointed out the yards without being asked, here and here and that one, and they understood that he was showing them where he had stood.

II. Three Ways

The Skog parsonage · the second week

THE PARSONAGE HAD BEEN EMPTY TWO YEARS. THE CONGREGATION stocked its kitchen the first Sunday, and what they stocked it with told the four of them everything: a sack of macaroni, a block of the government cheese, two jars of beans, a dozen eggs, and a note saying somebody would bring milk.

By the second week it was gone, and they sat down at the kitchen table to talk about the summer the way you would talk about a long drive on a quarter tank.

We could work for them, Curt said. *Walk beans. Chop silage in September. A man feeds his help.*

You don't have to break your back, said Lori. *Half these places the woman's working nights at the turkey plant and the old folks can't drive. We run their errands. Take Grandma to the clinic, carry word between the places. They'd keep us for that.*

Todd let them both finish. He was the one who could talk.

There's no call for either. Think what they're hungry for out here. All we have to do is speak well of each other.

He laid it out. When Curt was out of the room, the rest would let it be known that Curt had the gift of healing, that there was a woman in Montevideo with her goiter gone. Lori got a word of knowledge; she knew what was wrong in a house before she was through the porch. Peg had seen the Lord in a hayfield near Hancock as plain as you see that stove. And Todd, they would say when Todd was not by, had fasted forty days the winter before and had not been the same since.

None of it was so. Peg said that, and then said nothing else. Nobody at the table decided anything aloud, and by Sunday they were doing it.

III. The Tables

Skog township · July to October

It went through the township in ten days. People had watched the television preachers come apart that spring, the one in Carolina with his secretary and the one in Tulsa who said God would call him home if the money did not come in. Here were four clean young people who asked for nothing, each one too modest to speak of his own gift, so that you had to hear of it from the others. Nothing so good had come to Skog before, people said, and they said it to one another in the church basement with real gladness.

And they fed them. Marlys Thorson took the last white package marked ROAST out of the chest freezer, from the steer they had butchered in 1985, and set it in the sink to thaw. Her own three ate buttered noodles at the counter that week and were told to go outside while company was at the table. Old Arne Dahl opened his wife's pears, with 1983 on the lid in her hand, which he had not been able to open since the funeral. The Schmiesings had Curt pray over a boy's ears and sent him home with a pie, a quart of pickled beets and four dollars in an envelope. Nobody's hired man got a second plate that summer, and nobody's mother in the nursing home got her Sunday chicken brought in. It went to the parsonage.

Todd let his belt out a hole in August. Lori's face cleared. They all had a good color, slept well, and got along together better than they ever had

in the creamery. Peg ate what was put in front of her and looked at the plate.

October came in dry, and the combines ran until midnight. On the seventeenth the Twins opened the World Series in the Metrodome, and for a week you could not go into a milk house or a grain truck in Swift County without hearing WCCO. Women who owed the Land Bank more than the place was worth waved a white Homer Hanky at a twelve-inch television. The Twins won two at home and lost three in St. Louis. The corn was in by the twenty-second.

IV. Game Six

The Lindquist place, south of Vang · Saturday, October 24

The Workers came in to the Colonel's yard that Saturday, as they did every fall, by ones and twos in borrowed cars. Most of them looked like the country they had come out of. The pair from Appleton had walked beans in July and forked silage in September, and the cords stood out in their necks. A girl who had been alone at Louriston had gone a whole size down in her dress, and her hands were split at the knuckles. They had eaten what their houses ate.

The four from Skog got out of Todd's Citation sleek as seals.

The Colonel was in the machine shed with the big door open and the barn radio turned up across the yard so he could hear it. The game had started at three, the only one of the Series played in the afternoon. He was selling his old pickup and wanted the hitch ball off it first, and the nut had rusted solid to the shank. So he had the drawbar in the vise and the torch on it. He greeted each of them as they came in without turning the flame aside.

You kept well? You got by up there? Got fed without trouble?

We kept well, Todd said. *We got by fine. We had no trouble at all.*

He had known since August. He had stood in every one of those yards and he still drank coffee in most of the kitchens. He asked anyway, because it was time to.

How was that managed?

They told him. Todd began it and could not make it sound like anything, and Peg finished. The others in the shed had stopped moving.

Was any of it so? The goiter. The hayfield.

No, Peg said.

For your bellies, then.

He shut off the torch. In the quiet they could hear the radio and the crowd under it. The Twins had just gone ahead.

I know what is in those freezers, he said. *I know it to the package. I sold half of those freezers once and I may sell the rest. You sat down and ate Marlys Thorson's children's meat, and you told her a lie to get it.*

Then he said the two places, the second as slowly as the first.

> *Bread of falsehood is sweet to a man; But afterwards his mouth shall be filled with gravel.*
>
> *— Proverbs 20:17*
>
> *Woe unto the shepherds of Israel that do feed themselves! should not the shepherds feed the sheep? Ye eat the fat, and ye clothe you with the wool, ye kill the fatlings; but ye feed not the sheep.*
>
> *— Ezekiel 34:2–3*

The nut had come loose with the heat. He spun it off with the tongs and knocked the ball out of the drawbar onto the anvil, where it sat and glowed, a two-inch ball of iron gone the orange of a yard light.

You would have done better to swallow that, he said, *than one more plate up there.*

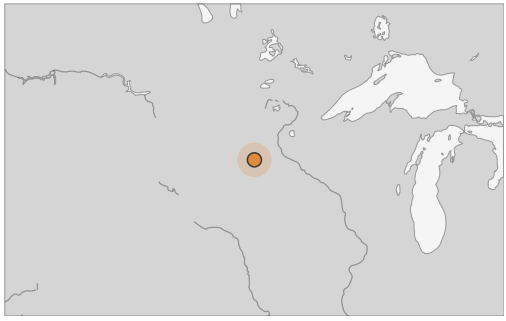
Nobody answered him. Across the yard the radio went up in a roar that did not stop, a hundred and twenty miles off, fifty-five thousand people on their feet for a ball gone over a fence with the bases full. Not one person in the shed turned toward it. They stood and watched the ball on the anvil go from orange to red, and from red to a blue-gray scale. It was a long time before anyone could have picked it up.

Background

The verse

> *Better it would be to swallow a heated iron ball, like flaring fire, than that a bad unrestrained fellow should live on the charity of the land.*
>
> Dhammapada 308, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, which takes the story from the monastic rule, a group of monks who are friends spend the rainy season on the banks of the Vaggumudā river in a year of famine, when the crops have turned to straw. They talk over how to get fed. Some propose working for the householders, others carrying their messages. They settle on praising one another to the householders as men of high spiritual attainment. The people, delighted, give them food they do not eat themselves or give to their own parents, children and workers. When the rains end and the monks of the region gather before the Buddha, the rest are gaunt and these are sleek. He asks how they fared, though he knows; they tell him; he asks whether the claims were true, rebukes them, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story.



Swift County, Minnesota

Western Minnesota, 1987

The farm crisis of the 1980s was the worst time on the land since the Depression. The average value of an acre of Minnesota farmland fell from $1,165 in 1982 to $700 in 1987, while the debts taken on against the higher figure stayed. The state began a Farm Advocate program in 1984 and required lenders to offer mediation before foreclosure in 1986; more than 600 Minnesota farmers still filed for bankruptcy in 1987. Corn that fall brought well under two dollars a bushel. It was also the year the television ministries of Jim Bakker and Oral Roberts were in the news for months. The Harvest Workers, Vang and the Skog church are invented; Swift County and Benson are real.

The 1987 World Series ran from October 17 to October 25, and the home team won every game. Game Six, on Saturday the twenty-fourth, started at three in the afternoon Central time, the last Series game played by day. The Twins trailed 5–2, and Kent Hrbek's grand slam in the sixth inning put it away, 11–5. They won the seventh game the next night. Herb Carneal and John Gordon called the games on WCCO radio, which reaches most of the Upper Midwest, and the Homer Hanky was new that October.

After the story of the bhikkhus who lived on the banks of the Vaggumudā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 308). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version (1901). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

22.4

Two Ribbons

Can a man take fire in his bosom, and his clothes not be burned?
— Proverbs 6:27 (Revised Version)

Na ou fa'alogo fa'apea, at the long tables behind the church on South Tacoma Way.

I. The Rear Detachment

Lakewood, Washington · summer 2009

Everyone in Lakewood who knew the Aumua family knew that the youngest son was too good-looking, and said so, the way you might say a house was too close to the river.

Iosefa Aumua was twenty-two. He had his mother's eyes, long-lashed and slow, and his father's shoulders, and a smile that he did not seem to know he was using. When he was small the aunties at church passed him from lap to lap and pinched his cheeks until he cried. When he was fifteen the girls from three high schools came to his wrestling meets and sat together in the bleachers in a row and did not watch the other matches. At seventeen he won the state title at his weight at Mat Classic in the Tacoma Dome, pinned a boy from Yakima in the third period, and when the referee raised his arm the noise from the Samoan side of the stands was so loud that people on the other mats stopped to look.

His father was Tavita Aumua, Command Sergeant Major, retired. Thirty years in the Army, three wars, a Bronze Star from Mosul he never spoke of, and on the Samoan side of Lakewood he held the family's chiefly title and was called Leaupepe, and on the other side everybody from the post commander's driver to the Korean grocer on South Tacoma Way called him Sergeant Major. He worked now as a civilian on post, in the building where soldiers were processed before they deployed. Every

soldier at Fort Lewis who had gone to Iraq or Afghanistan since 2006 had passed by his desk, and he had looked at every one of them over his reading glasses and asked whether their wills were in order, and a good many of the officers on post had been lieutenants under him once, and remembered.

Iosefa, whom everyone called Sefa, had enlisted the summer after high school, because his father had and his father's brothers had, and because in American Samoa, where the family came from, so many households had someone in the Army. He made it through basic and through his first year in a Stryker infantry company at Fort Lewis. Then in the spring of 2009, in a pickup game of basketball behind the barracks, he came down wrong on his left knee and tore it apart, and the surgeons at Madigan rebuilt it with a piece of tendon from his hamstring. In July his brigade left for Kandahar without him. He stayed behind on the rear detachment, on a profile, limping, issuing parts in the motor pool, with a few dozen other soldiers who were sick or hurt or waiting on paperwork, and the wives and children of the whole brigade all around him in the family housing and the apartments off Gravelly Lake Drive.

There is a cadence the Army has sung on morning runs since the Second World War, about a man named Jody. Jody is the one who stays home. Jody drives your car and wears your clothes and sleeps in your bed while you are overseas, and the platoon sings his name in time with its feet, and laughs, because the joke is that every man running has a Jody somewhere and does not know his name.

That summer, at Fort Lewis, his name was Sefa.

It started with the wife of a sergeant from his own company. She had a baby and a toddler and a husband in a valley in Afghanistan whose name she could not pronounce, and her car would not start, and Sefa, who was in the parking lot of the commissary, fixed it. He did not mean anything by it. He never meant anything by it. That was the thing about him that his mother, years later, would try to explain to people and fail. The women looked at him and could not look away, and he let them, and did not think, and the not thinking was a kind of sweetness in him, like the smile, that made it worse.

II. The First Time

Family housing, Fort Lewis · August

THE MILITARY POLICE FOUND HIM AT TWO IN THE MORNING IN the second week of August, coming over the back fence of a duplex in the family housing, with his shoes in his hand.

A neighbor had called it in as a prowler. Two MPs came with flashlights and put him against their car and asked him what he was doing, and he told them the truth, more or less, because he could not think of anything else, and one of them laughed and the other did not. They took him to the station. In the morning, because he was a soldier, they called his unit, and his unit sent the rear detachment commander, a tired major named Ochoa who had three hundred families to look after and a list on his office wall of the brigade's wounded and dead that grew every week.

Major Ochoa had been a lieutenant in Mosul in 2004, and the platoon sergeant beside him there had been a staff sergeant named Tavita Aumua, who had kept him alive at least twice and taught him most of what he knew about being an officer.

He read the blotter. He looked through the glass at Sefa, sitting on the bench in the hallway in yesterday's T-shirt with his shoes still in his hand, and he saw the Sergeant Major's face in the boy's face, and he felt something he would describe later to his wife as shame, though it was not his shame. He thought about what he was supposed to do. Adultery was a crime under the Uniform Code of Military Justice, Article 134, if it brought discredit on the service, and this was the kind of thing that brought discredit. The woman's husband was in a platoon that had lost two men the week before.

The major tore the page out of the blotter, folded it into quarters and put it in his pocket. He went out into the hallway and stood in front of Sefa for a moment. Then, without saying anything to him at all, he jerked his head toward the door, and Sefa got up and went out.

He did not tell the Sergeant Major. He told himself it would not happen again.

III. The Knock

An apartment off Gravelly Lake Drive · September

IT HAPPENED AGAIN.

The second woman's husband was a specialist in the scouts, and she lived in an apartment complex outside the gate, off Gravelly Lake Drive, with a view of the parking lot and a picture of him in his uniform on the television. She was twenty years old. She had come out from Ohio to marry him a month before he deployed, and she did not know anyone in Washington, and it rained.

At six-thirty on a Sunday morning in September, somebody knocked on her door.

Sefa woke at the sound and saw her face. She was sitting straight up in the bed, with the sheet held against her, absolutely still, and her face had gone the color of the wall.

Every wife at Fort Lewis knew about the knock. The Army did not tell you on the telephone. When your husband was killed the Army sent two soldiers in dress greens to your door, an officer and a chaplain, and they stood on your step until you opened it, and you knew before they said a word. They came between six in the morning and ten at night. Every woman in that apartment complex had at some point looked out a window at a car pulling into the lot and stopped breathing until it parked in front of somebody else's door. That autumn the brigade's dead were coming home from the Arghandab valley week after week. There had been memorials at the chapel on post nearly every Thursday. The women went to all of them.

The knock came again. She got up, holding the sheet, and went down the hall like a sleepwalker, and he heard her open the door.

It was not the notification team. It was two MPs. The woman downstairs, whose husband was in the same troop, had seen a man go up the stairs at midnight and had called the gate.

He heard what she said to them in the doorway. It was not words, really. It was the sound a person makes when they have been dropped from a great height and caught at the last second, and it was relief, and

terror, and shame, all in the one breath, and he would hear it at night for years.

He sat on the edge of the bed in her husband's apartment and looked at her husband's picture on the television, and he was afraid too. He was more afraid than he had been on the mat in the Tacoma Dome, more afraid than on the operating table at Madigan, and the fear was not of the MPs. It was of what he had just heard. And the strange thing, the thing he could not have explained to anyone, was how little there had been underneath all that fear, how small the thing was that they had been doing, the two of them, in the dark, frightened, listening for cars.

The MPs took him in again. Major Ochoa came again. He looked at the report and looked at the boy on the bench, and he thought about the specialist in the scouts, and he thought about Staff Sergeant Aumua in Mosul pulling him down behind a wall by his body armor. He tore the page out of the blotter a second time. This time he did not even go out into the hallway. He sent a sergeant to tell Sefa he could go.

IV. The Third Time

Lakewood · October

The third time it was a Samoan woman, and that was the end of it, because there are no secrets on the Samoan side of Lakewood. Her husband was a sergeant in the same brigade, from a family in Carson that knew the Aumuas, and her mother-in-law sang in the same church choir as Sefa's mother. The MPs caught him in the parking lot of her building at four in the morning, sitting in his truck with the engine off, waiting for her neighbor's lights to go out. There was nothing on the blotter but a man in a truck. Major Ochoa let him go a third time, and said nothing a third time, and went home and told his wife he did not know what he was going to do.

But by the next Sunday the women of the church knew. By Sunday night the men knew, and by Monday morning Sefa's uncle Pita knew, because Pita knew everything that happened among the Samoans of Pierce County, sooner or later, across his kitchen table.

Pita was the Sergeant Major's older brother. He had never been in the Army. He had worked thirty years on the docks at the Port of Tacoma, and since he retired he had done one thing, which was feed people. Every Sunday after church his house on the Hilltop filled up with whoever was hungry, young soldiers far from home, Tongans, Fijians, white boys from Kentucky in their PT shorts, old men who lived alone, a homeless veteran who came every week and never said his name. Pita made an umu in the backyard, an earth oven, when it was not raining, and when it was raining he made one anyway under a blue tarp, and there was taro and palusami, the young taro leaves cooked in coconut cream, and pork, and chop suey the Samoan way, and he sent everybody home with a foil pan. People said nobody in Tacoma had gone hungry on a Sunday in twenty years if they knew the way to Pita's. People called his house the Hilltop Embassy. When he retired, his wife had wanted to go home to the family land in Leone, on Tutuila, and so had he, and the tickets were bought, and in the end he stayed, and sent her for a month every year instead, because, he said, if he went home, who would cook?

Pita drove to his brother's house on Monday morning and sat down at the kitchen table and told him.

The Sergeant Major did not say anything for a long time. Then he took off his reading glasses and folded them and put them in his shirt pocket. He telephoned Major Ochoa, and Major Ochoa, who had been dreading the call for two months, told him everything, all three times, and apologized, and the Sergeant Major said, *Sir, you did nothing wrong, you did me a kindness,* and hung up, and sat at the kitchen table with his hands flat on it.

Sefa came home from the motor pool at five. His father was still sitting there.

Put on a white shirt, said his father. *And your lavalava. We're going to see the faifeau.*

V. The Faifeau

The parsonage, South Tacoma · that evening

The Reverend Elisaia Tuilagi had come to Seattle from Apia in 1964, the year the first Samoan Congregational church in Washington was started in the south end of Seattle, and he had been the pastor of the Samoan church in Tacoma for thirty-one years. He was seventy-nine. He had baptized Sefa, and Sefa's older brothers and sisters, and he had married the Sergeant Major's daughters and buried the Sergeant Major's mother. He was a heavy, slow, silent man with a white crew cut and enormous hands, and on Sundays he preached in Samoan for an hour and the children slept against their mothers and the old people wept, and on weekdays he hardly spoke at all.

His wife let them in. The parsonage smelled of fried bananas and of the rain. The Reverend Elisaia was sitting in an armchair in the front room, under a framed picture of the church in Apia where he had been ordained, with his Bible on his knee, and he did not get up. The Sergeant Major sat down on the couch. Sefa remained standing, because nobody told him to sit.

Faifeau, said his father, *my son has something to tell you.* And then, to Sefa, in the voice that had once carried across parade grounds: *All of it.*

So Sefa told the old man all of it, standing in the front room of the parsonage in his white shirt and lavalava with his hands at his sides. He told it badly, with long stops. He told about the car at the commissary and the fence and the shoes in his hand. He told about the apartment off Gravelly Lake Drive and the picture on the television. He told about the knock, and when he got to the sound she had made at the door, he could not go on for a while, and nobody helped him. He told about the woman in Carson's family and the truck in the parking lot. He told about Major Ochoa tearing the page out of the blotter three times without saying a word to him.

When he was finished, his father said, quietly, to the old man, *Teach him. Please. I can't.*

The Reverend Elisaia had listened to all of it with his eyes closed. He opened them now and looked at Sefa for a long time, a heavy, unhurried, not unkind look, the way a man looks at weather coming in over the water. Then he opened the Bible on his knee, which was the Samoan Bible the missionaries had made, and read from Proverbs in Samoan. Then, because Sefa's Samoan was a church Samoan, a grandmother Samoan, good for prayers and scoldings and not much else, he took the old English Revised Version from the side table, which had been given to him when he was a young man in Apia, and read the same thing again in English, slowly, with his finger on the page.

> *Can a man take fire in his bosom, and his clothes not be burned? Or can one walk upon hot coals, and his feet not be scorched?*
>
> *He that committeth adultery with a woman is void of understanding: he doeth it that would destroy his own soul. Wounds and dishonour shall he get; and his reproach shall not be wiped away.*
>
> *— Proverbs 6:27–28, 32–33 (Revised Version)*

He closed the book on his finger.

Four things, he said. His voice was very deep and very quiet. *I have watched this happen to men for fifty years, in Apia and Pago and Seattle and here. There are four things, always. First the soul. You lose something you cannot buy back. Second the bed. You have not slept, I think.*

Sefa shook his head. He had not slept through a night since September.

You lie down on coals. Third, the name. Your name, your father's name, his title, your mother at choir practice. Fourth, and he opened the book again and turned back a few pages, *this.*

> *Stolen waters are sweet, and bread eaten in secret is pleasant. But he knoweth not that the dead are there; that her guests are in the depths of Sheol.*
>
> *— Proverbs 9:17–18 (Revised Version)*

Sweet, said the old man. *Tell me how sweet it was. A man who is afraid and a woman who is afraid, in the dark, listening for the car. Tell me how sweet.*

Sefa could not answer.

And the husbands, said the Reverend Elisaia, *are soldiers. And the Army has its law, and the major will not tear up the paper a fourth time. And one of these husbands will come home from Kandahar, and nobody will tear up anything. That is the rage of a man, the book says. He will not regard any ransom. You know that. Your father knows that. The major knew it, and was kind to you three times, for your father's sake, and you used up his kindness like a boy using up his mother's money.*

He was quiet for a while. The rain ran down the window behind him.

But the worst is not the husbands, he said. *The worst is the dead. You heard the woman at the door. You heard what was in her. Those women go to the chapel every Thursday and stand there with their children for the men who are not coming home, and you went into their houses. That is the place the book means. You have been living in the depths, my son, with the dead all around you, and you did not know where you were.*

Sefa stood in the front room of the parsonage, and something gave way in him.

He said afterward that it was like the knee, in the basketball game behind the barracks, that moment of coming down and hearing the inside of himself make a sound, and knowing before the pain came that something had changed and was not going to change back. He saw the women's faces, all three of them, and their husbands' faces in the pictures, and Major Ochoa's face, and his father's, and his mother's at choir practice, and he saw the knock at the door and the sound, and he saw himself, and it was as if he had been looking at everything through a window with the curtains drawn and somebody had opened them. He did not fall down. He stood there in his lavalava and wept like a child, without covering his face, and his father did not look away, and the old man did not look away, and the rain came down on South Tacoma Way.

The Reverend Elisaia's wife said later that she had heard it from the kitchen, and had put the bananas aside, and had known there was no need to go in.

VI. The Ribbons

The church on South Tacoma Way · November

He went to Major Ochoa the next morning, by himself, and asked to make a statement. The major looked at him for a long moment, then got out the form. Sefa took an Article 15 that winter and a reduction in rank, and a letter in his file that followed him the rest of his time in the Army, and he did not complain about any of it. In January he wrote three letters, and the Reverend Elisaia read them and told him to burn two of them, and he did, and mailed the third, to the husband in Carson's family, who did not answer. Some debts are not paid. He knew that now. He went to the chapel on post every Thursday that the memorials went on, and stood at the very back, by the door, in uniform, and left before the end, so as not to be seen.

The women stopped looking at him. Or perhaps they looked at him the same as before, and he did not notice, because he no longer looked back. His mother said that his face had changed; that it was the same face, and that she could not explain it. Uncle Pita said it was simpler than that. He said the boy had finally put down a fork and gone to wash the dishes.

On the Sunday before Thanksgiving, after the service, the Reverend Elisaia called Sefa over to the front of the church, near the pulpit, where the big brass cross hung on the wall above the communion table, polished every Saturday by the women's committee until it shone like gold. The old man pointed up at it with one enormous hand. Two ribbons were tied around the foot of the cross, at the back, where you could hardly see them from the pews. They had been there so long that they were the color of the wall. One had been red once, and one blue.

You remember, said the Reverend Elisaia.

Sefa remembered. He had not thought of it in five years.

It was the Sunday after Mat Classic, when he was seventeen. He had come to church with his two medals, the regional and the state, in the pocket of his good trousers, and after the service, while everybody was outside on the steps, he had climbed up on the communion table in his

socks and tied the two ribbons from the medals around the foot of the cross, because a cousin had dared him and because he was happy. Then, standing on the table, with his arms up, he had said a prayer out loud, the kind of prayer a boy of seventeen says to make his cousins laugh. He had asked God to make every girl who ever saw him fall in love with him. Then, being careful, he had added: except my sisters, and my cousins. His cousins had laughed until they fell into the pews, and the Reverend Elisaia, who had come back in for his glasses, had stood in the doorway and watched the whole thing, and said nothing, and never taken the ribbons down.

Children pray for all kinds of things, said the old man. *Most of the time God is merciful and does not listen. Sometimes He gives them what they ask, so they can find out what it weighs.*

Sefa climbed up on the communion table in his socks. He reached up behind the brass cross and untied the two ribbons, one and then the other, slowly, with his fingers, because the knots had gone hard as wood, and climbed down. He stood in front of the pulpit with them in his open hand. They were light as nothing. They had faded to the color of dust, one with a little pink still in it along the fold and one with a little grey, and they lay across his palm in the light from the windows like two dry leaves.

Background

The verses

> *Four things does a wreckless man gain who covets his neighbour's wife,—a bad reputation, an uncomfortable bed, thirdly, punishment, and lastly, hell.*
>
> Dhammapada 309, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *There is bad reputation, and the evil way (to hell), there is the short pleasure of the frightened in the arms of the frightened, and the king imposes heavy punishment; therefore let no man think of his neighbour's wife.*
>
> Dhammapada 310, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Khema, a rich man's son and nephew of the great donor Anāthapiṇḍika, is so handsome that women who see him cannot help themselves, and he runs after other men's wives. Three times the king's men arrest him at night, and three times the king, ashamed before the boy's father, lets him go without a word. When the father hears, he takes his son to the Buddha and makes him tell the whole story, and the Buddha answers with these verses; Khema is stirred to conscience and enters the stream. The commentary explains his beauty by a past life: as a champion wrestler in the time of an earlier Buddha, he planted two colored banners on a golden shrine and wished that every woman who saw him, except his kinswomen, would fall in love with him. Read the full commentary story.

Lakewood and Fort Lewis, Washington

Fort Lewis, 2009

In the summer of 2009 a Stryker brigade from Fort Lewis deployed to Kandahar province in the war in Afghanistan and took heavy losses in the Arghandab valley that autumn. On February 1, 2010, Fort Lewis and McChord Air Force Base merged into Joint Base Lewis–McChord, the Army's main installation west of the Rockies, beside Lakewood and Tacoma. Deaths are reported to families in person by a uniformed casualty notification team. Adultery that brought discredit on the service was a crime under Article 134 of the Uniform Code of Military Justice; since 2019 the offense has been called extramarital sexual conduct. Soldiers have long sung about "Jody," the civilian who stays home with your girl, in the marching chants called jody calls.

Samoan Americans have served in the U.S. armed forces in large numbers since the Second World War, and the Seattle–Tacoma area has one of the larger Samoan communities on the mainland; the first Samoan Christian Congregational church in Washington was founded in southeast Seattle in 1964. Washington's high school wrestling championships, Mat Classic, are held each February in the Tacoma Dome. The Reverend Elisaia reads Proverbs from the Samoan Bible translated by the London Missionary Society, and then from the English Revised Version of 1885.

After the story of Khema from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 309 and 310). The original. Scripture from the English Revised Version (1885). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.5

Two Strokes

He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much.
— Luke 16:10

So I'm told, on the cart paths in Peachtree City.

I. The Seventh Hole

Peachtree City, Georgia · September 2006

Monday was the day off, and on Mondays the two associate pastors of Aberdeen Presbyterian Church played eighteen at Line Creek, the public course on the south side of town, with a 7:10 tee time that Brad Tolleson had held every week for six years and would not give up for funerals. They drove over on the cart path from their houses, past the Kroger and the middle school and the long fingers of Lake Peachtree, in Brad's cart, which had a church parking sticker on the windshield and a cup holder he had installed himself that would hold a Chick-fil-A sweet tea in the large size. Gene Wofford and Ron Kiser, both elders, made up the foursome. Gene had been a mechanic for Delta for thirty-one years and still looked up at every plane.

Scott Lindahl was the associate for pastoral care. He was thirty-nine and kind and nearly always somewhere else in his head, usually a hospital room. Brad was the associate for discipleship, which meant the youth and the men's breakfast and the mission trip to Honduras. He was forty-six and had sold corporate travel accounts for Delta before seminary and could still close anything. People in the congregation said that Scott was the one you wanted when your mother was dying and Brad was the one you wanted when you were sixteen, and both of these were true.

That June the General Assembly had met in Birmingham and voted, two hundred ninety-eight to two hundred twenty-one, that a candidate for ordination could declare a scruple, a point of conscience on which he could not in good faith go along with the church's standards, and the presbytery examining him would decide whether the departure touched anything essential. Half the presbytery thought the church had finally found a way to keep its people together, and half thought it had found a way to let anything through. Scott and Brad had agreed in July not to talk about it on Mondays. They talked about it anyway, every Monday, somewhere around the sixth hole.

The seventh at Line Creek is a short par four that doglegs left around a pond, and the developer had ringed the pond in the eighties with pampas grass, great fountains of it taller than a man, with silver plumes in the fall that the women of the town cut for their front halls. Scott pulled his drive into the rough short of the pampas. He walked to his ball with a seven iron, still thinking about the man at the hospice in Fayetteville he had to see at two, whose daughters were not speaking to each other across the bed. He stood over the ball. Without noticing he did it, he reached down and pulled a blade of grass from just behind it, a long stiff blade standing up in the Bermuda, and put the end of it in his mouth.

Then he noticed. He stood still with the grass in his teeth.

Brad. What happens to a guy who breaks off a blade of grass behind his ball?

Brad laughed out loud. He was standing by the cart with his glove off, eating peanuts out of the pack.

You're asking if it's a penalty.

Is it?

Technically. Improving the lie. Two strokes. He tipped the last of the peanuts into his mouth. *Scotty. Nobody saw it but me and God, and God's got bigger fish. You want to feel better, call it on yourself, write down two more, and you're clean as a whistle. That's the beauty of this game. It's the only one where you confess. Confession and absolution, brother. Most Presbyterian game there is.*

I just wasn't paying attention, Scott said.

That's what I'm telling you. It doesn't matter. Watch.

He walked over to the edge of the pond, to the nearest clump of pampas grass, where the long leaves arched out and down over the water like the tail of a horse, and took a big double handful of them, one fist above the other, the way you take hold of a rope.

Grace abounds, Brad said, and pulled.

The clump did not come up. The leaves came through his fists instead, fast, all of them, and the edges of pampas grass are lined with teeth too small to see. He let go and looked down at his hands. For a moment there was nothing on them but a pattern of fine white lines, crossing, as though somebody had drawn on his palms with a pin. Then the lines filled in red, all at once, and began to run.

Gene Wofford was out of his cart before anybody else had moved. He wrapped Brad's hands in two of the white towels off the bag rack, tight, and held them up above his head for him, and Ron drove. Scott took the grass out of his mouth, looked at it, and followed them in.

II. The Grill Room

Line Creek clubhouse · the same morning

The Monday ladies' nine had finished early and were in the grill room at the round table by the window, under the television, eating chicken salad. Dot Huckaby was at the end of the table. She was seventy-six. She had been an operating-room nurse at Piedmont Hospital in Atlanta for forty-one years, scrub and then circulating and then in charge of the whole floor, and when she retired to Peachtree City she had joined Aberdeen Presbyterian and become a ruling elder, and then the chair of the personnel committee, which was the committee to which both associate pastors answered. She drove a green cart with a Braves magnet on the back. She kept a first-aid kit under the seat of it that would have done credit to a small hospital.

Gene came in ahead of the others and went straight to her.

Dot, you're not going to believe what your preachers just did.

She did not ask. She went out to her cart and came back with the kit and a bottle of water, and sat Brad down on a chair at the next table, and

unwrapped the towels, and looked at his hands for a long time without saying anything, turning them over in hers. Then she washed them, one at a time, with the water, over a stack of paper napkins, while Gene told it and Ron filled in and Scott stood behind them with his hands in his pockets.

She did not say anything while they told it. When they were finished she took a pair of tweezers out of the kit and began picking the little hairs of the plant out of the cuts.

Scott, she said, without looking up. *Where were you?*

Ma'am?

When you pulled that grass. Where were you?

Scott thought about it. *At the hospice. With Mr. Pittman.*

That's right. You weren't at your ball. You were standing over it and you were in Fayetteville, and your hand went down and pulled something up and put it in your mouth, and you didn't know it till it was done. She held one of Brad's fingers still and worked at the cut. *Forty-one years I counted sponges. Every one that ever got left inside a person got left by somebody standing at the table thinking about something else. Nobody leaves a sponge on purpose. That's the whole trouble with it.*

> *He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much: and he that is unjust in the least is unjust also in much.*
>
> *— Luke 16:10*

Yes, ma'am, said Scott.

She tore open a packet of the paper adhesive strips she used for closing cuts and began laying them across Brad's left palm, one after another, very straight.

And you, she said. *What was it you told him? Call it on yourself and you're clean?*

Brad started to smile and then didn't.

Let me tell you about clean, Dot said. *In my room, when you break scrub, you say so. Out loud. I've touched. My glove's gone. Nobody thinks any less of you for saying it. A first-year resident says it, the chief of surgery says it, you say*

it. That part's easy. Then you step back from the table, and you go out to the sink, and you scrub again, from the elbows down, five minutes by the clock, every finger, under every nail, and you come back in and somebody gowns you and gloves you all over again from the beginning. Saying it isn't the clean. Saying it is so you'll go get clean.

She laid another strip.

I had a surgeon once, a good one, who said it and kept his hands in the patient. I've touched, so what, let's close. I watched what that did, over a couple of years, to every young doctor who stood across the table from him. They learned it from him. They didn't learn it from the textbook. They learned it from a man they looked up to who said the words and didn't mean them. She looked up at Brad for the first time. *Who is going to stand across from you on Wednesday night, Brad?*

Brad did not answer. There were sixty kids in the youth group. He knew every one of their names.

You took the sweetest thing we've got, Dot said, *that you can tell the truth about yourself and be forgiven, and you used it to make fun of a man for caring about a blade of grass. Then you grabbed a whole bush to show him how little it all mattered. And look what it did to you.*

> *As a thorn goeth up into the hand of a drunkard, so is a parable in the mouths of fools.*
>
> *— Proverbs 26:9*

The grill room had gone quiet. The ladies of the Monday nine were all watching, with their forks down, and the boy behind the counter had turned off the blender. On the television the Braves were losing a replay from the night before with the sound off.

Dot finished the right hand. She wrapped each palm in gauze and taped it, neatly, the way she had done ten thousand times, and then she held both of his hands in both of hers, palms up, for a moment, as if she were weighing them.

You'll want two stitches in the right one. I'm not doing it in a grill room. Ron, take him to the urgent care on 54. Scott, go see Mr. Pittman. She let go of the

hands. *And both of you. Whatever it is you're going to do, do it. Either be a preacher or go back to selling airplane seats. Don't do it halfway. Halfway is what gets on everybody.*

> *Whatsoever thy hand findeth to do, do it with thy might.*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 9:10*

She snapped the kit shut and went back to her chicken salad.

III. Monday

Line Creek · October 2006

Brad did not play for three Mondays. He preached on the second Sunday of October with both hands taped, and held them up at the start of the sermon and told the congregation exactly how it had happened, every word he had said on the seventh hole, and then preached on something else entirely, and the youth group talked about it for a month.

Something changed in him after that, though nobody at Aberdeen Presbyterian could have said exactly when. He started returning phone calls the same day. He stopped telling the story about the mission trip to Honduras in which he was the hero. The youth noticed that when he said he would be somewhere, he was there, early. When the personnel committee did his review in the spring, Dot Huckaby wrote one line in the comments box, in her square nurse's hand, and nobody else on the committee ever saw what it said.

On the fourth Monday of October he was back on the first tee at 7:10, with new pink lines across both palms where the cuts had closed, and a rule book in his back pocket, the little USGA one that nobody ever carries. The dew was still on the fairways. Every ball that rolled through it left a dark line behind it, curving where the ground curved, and the lines lay there behind them all the way up the first hole and only began to dry when the sun got over the pines.

On the seventh, Brad pulled his drive. It went left and short and kicked into the pampas grass on the bank above the pond, outside the stakes, and stayed there, down in the middle of a clump, among the stems.

He walked over and looked at it for a long time with his hands at his sides. Gene and Ron and Scott waited in the carts. Nobody said anything. Then he took out the rule book and found the page, and declared the ball unplayable, and took his penalty stroke, and dropped within two club lengths, no nearer the hole, and played on.

On the card, in the box for the seventh hole, he wrote a six, and next to it, small, a one with a circle around it, so that anybody who looked would know where it had come from.

Background

The verses

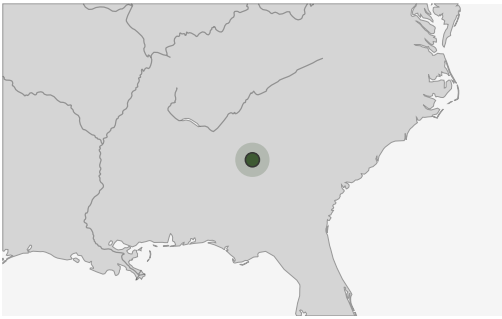
> *As a grass-blade, if badly grasped, cuts the arm, badly-practised asceticism leads to hell.*
>
> Dhammapada 311, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *An act carelessly performed, a broken vow, and hesitating obedience to discipline, all this brings no great reward.*
>
> Dhammapada 312, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If anything is to be done, let a man do it, let him attack it vigorously! A careless pilgrim only scatters the dust of his passions more widely.*
>
> Dhammapada 313, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk thoughtlessly breaks off a single blade of grass, and, troubled in conscience, asks another monk what happens to a monk who does that. The other tells him nothing happens; he has only to confess it and he is free; and to show him, he seizes a clump of grass with both hands and pulls it up. The monks report it to the Buddha, who rebukes him soundly and speaks the three verses on grass wrongly grasped, the lax deed and the careless wanderer. The stubborn monk afterward becomes steady in restraint and reaches awakening. Read the full commentary story, or about the Vinaya, the monastic discipline, whose list of rules for monks says

that "the damaging of a living plant is to be confessed" (the Bhikkhu Pāṭimokkha, tr. Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu).



Peachtree City, Georgia

Peachtree City, 2006

Peachtree City, south of Atlanta in Fayette County, was chartered in 1959 as a planned community of villages, among them Aberdeen, Braelinn, Glenloch and Kedron, each with its own shops, schools and recreation. Miles of paved paths connect the neighborhoods, churches and schools, and residents drive golf carts on them as an ordinary way of getting around. On June 20, 2006, the 217th General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.), meeting in Birmingham, voted 298 to 221 to adopt an authoritative interpretation, drawn from the 1729 Adopting Act, under which a candidate for ordination may declare a "scruple" and the ordaining body decides whether it departs from essentials of the church's standards (Presbyterian News Service, via Worldwide Faith News). The church, the course and the people in the story are invented.

Under the Rules of Golf in force in 2006, a player who improved the lie of the ball by bending or breaking anything growing was penalized two strokes in stroke play (USGA, Rule 13); golf is unusual among sports in expecting players to call penalties on themselves. A ball may be declared unplayable anywhere except in a water hazard, at a cost of one stroke. Pampas grass, an ornamental from South America planted widely in Southern yards and developments in the late twentieth century, has leaves with fine saw-toothed edges that cut skin easily (LawnLove).

After the story of a stubborn bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 311–313). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.6

The Ear-Mark

Who seeth us? and who knoweth us?
— Isaiah 29:15

Zo heb ik het horen zeggen, on the Esopus flats.

I. The Mark Book

Marbletown, Ulster County, New York · 1826

Meester Wessel Brink had been voorlezer of the stone church at the Steenkill for forty-one years. He had kept the school beside it for most of those, and for thirty he had kept the town's books as well, because he wrote the clearest hand between Hurley and the mountains. One of the books was the mark book. Every farmer on the flats turned his sheep onto the commons and his hogs into the oak woods, and a man knew his own in the fall by the cut of their ears, and the cut was the Meester's to write down. *Petrus Oosterhoudt, a halfpenny under each ear. Widow Roosa, a swallow fork in the right. Jacobus Krom, his mark: a crop off the left ear and a slit in the right. Recorded this 2d day of April 1798.* For the first pages he had drawn a small sheep's head beside each entry, with the ears done carefully. After that the town grew and he left off drawing.

He was seventy-nine now. The consistory called him the clerk, and the town had voted in a younger man for its books, and the dominie rode over from Rochester three Sundays in five and preached in English. But on the Sundays between, the old people still came, and the Meester stood at his desk under the pulpit and read them a chapter out of the States Bible with the brass clasps, in the Dutch it was printed in, and lined out a psalm, and they sang it slowly and went home. He had spent his life saying other people's words aloud, and it had left him with very few of his

own. Children who had been his scholars and were grandfathers now could not remember him saying ten sentences together.

Jacobus Krom had a hundred and forty acres of the flat land along the creek, in wheat and flax and Indian corn, and the stone house his grandfather built, with the kitchen in the cellar and the best room, the opkamer, raised four steps above the rest. His wife was Catrina, an Oosterhoudt from Hurley, whom everybody called Trijntje. They had been married twenty-six years. There were three small stones in the churchyard with the name Krom on them and no children in the house.

Trijntje Krom was a woman who counted. She counted the eggs and the candles, and the spoons on Saturday night. She knew to a skein what lay in the linen kas, and she knew it again the next week. It was called good housekeeping and it was. But there was something under it that was not housekeeping. She could not bear for a thing that was hers to be handled by anyone else.

There were two others in the house. Old Kees drove the team and slept in the barn loft in all weathers because of the horses. He had been bought at a vendue in Kingston in 1789 and was a slave for life, or until the Fourth of July next year, when the law said every one of them still held in the State of New York should go free. People on the flats called that day the Freedom, the way they would say the thaw.

And there was Dina. She had been born in the cellar kitchen in March of 1802, to a woman named Bet who belonged to Jacobus Krom, and the law made a difference of that. A child born after the Fourth of July, 1799, was born free, and owed her mother's master her work until she was five-and-twenty. The master had to carry the birth to the town clerk within nine months, and Jacobus had, and the Meester had written it in a book that was not the mark book. *Dina, a female child, born the 9th of March 1802 of Bet, the slave of Jacobus Krom.* So Dina was a servant, in the law's English, and in the Kroms' Dutch she was what her mother had been. Bet had died in the winter of 1819 and was buried at the wood's edge beyond the churchyard wall, where they put them.

Dina knew her date. She had ten months left. She did the washing and the milking and the cellar hearth, and she sold eggs at the door to the Ir-

ishmen who had come that year to dig the canal along the Rondout, and she kept her English for them and her Dutch for everything that mattered. She had a face that people looked at. The canal men looked, and the miller, and the young dominie, once, and then at his boots.

II. The Cellar Stairs

Winter and spring, 1826

Jacobus began coming down the cellar stairs after New Year, when his wife was asleep.

Dina slept on a straw tick by the cellar hearth. There was no door between her and the stairs and nobody within call. Nobody had ever asked Dina whether she was willing about anything, and Jacobus did not begin then. He did not think of himself as a hard man. He brought her a paper of brown sugar once from Kingston, and a ribbon, which she put in the fire.

By April Trijntje knew. There was the fourth stair, which spoke. There was tallow on the cuff of his nightshirt, and they burned no tallow upstairs. One night she got up after him and stood at the head of the stairs in the dark with her hand on the wall, and listened as long as she could stand to, and went back to bed and lay with her eyes open until the window turned grey.

She said nothing to him. She had been angry with Jacobus Krom for twenty-six years over smaller matters, and she knew the size of that anger and what it could not move. This was something else, and it wanted a place to go. It went down the stairs.

She watched Dina carry the milk. She watched her bend to the fire. She watched the canal men at the door with their hats in their hands, and it seemed to her, by May, that the whole of the trouble was in that face, that it had been set in her kitchen like a lamp in a window to bring men in off the road. She did not once think of the stairs as something Jacobus had walked down. She thought of them as something Dina had drawn him down. This is how it is told, and nobody on the flats has ever said it was sense.

The Saturday before Pinkster, Jacobus and Kees took the wagon to the landing at Kingston with the last of the winter flour, and would not be back before night. It was shearing week. The shears lay on the bench in the cellar kitchen with the little hooked knife beside them, because the lambs are marked when the ewes are shorn. Trijntje had held lambs for the marking every spring since she was a bride. She knew how it was done.

She called Dina up to the opkamer to help her wind yarn.

Hold out your hands.

Dina held them out, a foot apart, palms in, as she had a thousand times, for the skein to be laid over them. Trijntje laid on the skein, and then took a turn of it around both wrists, and another, and drew it tight, and knotted it. It was linen, her own spinning. It would have held a calf. Dina looked at her hands and then at her mistress, and had only begun to understand when Trijntje pushed her down against the foot of the bed and bound her ankles with the rest.

She did it the way it is done to a lamb, kneeling on her, quickly, with the left ear first. A crop off the left and a slit in the right. Then, because it was the face she wanted, she set the point of the knife in the nostril and laid it open to the bone.

Dina did not scream at first, because she did not believe it. Then she did. There was nobody on the flats to hear her but the shorn ewes in the fold, who lifted their heads.

Under the opkamer, reached from the cellar kitchen by a low plank door, was the root cellar, where the turnips and cabbages wintered. In May it was empty. Trijntje dragged her down the stairs and across the bricks and put her in, and shut the door, and rolled the vinegar barrel in front of it.

Then she scrubbed the opkamer floor with sand. She scalded the knife. She burned the ends of the yarn and her own apron. When it was all done she stood in her clean kitchen with her hands hanging and saw that she had not thought past this hour. The girl had run off to the canal with an Irishman. That would do for a day. She had not thought as far as a week.

III. Pinkster

Whitsunday, the 14th of May

Jacobus came home after midnight and went straight up. In the morning there was no fire in the cellar and no milk on the table.

She is gone, Trijntje said. *Her bed was not slept in. To the canal, I expect. They have been at the door all spring.*

Jacobus stood with one boot on. Something went across his face, and she saw that part of it was relief, and hated him freshly for it.

With ten months left, he said. *It makes no sense.*

When did that kind ever make sense? And then, with her back to him, taking her black silk out of the kas: *Kom, man. It is Pinkster. Let us go and hear the Meester read.*

He stared at her. It was an off Sunday, with no dominie. She had not sat through the Dutch reading in ten years. She said the old man's voice put her to sleep and the psalms ran so slow you could knit a stocking between the lines.

It is Pinkster, she said again. *People will look for us.*

That was the whole of her reason, and she had found it in the night. Whatever was discovered, and whenever, the entire church should be able to say where Trijntje Krom was on Pinkster morning. She was in her pew with her psalm book, among them, where she belonged.

Kees drove. It was a soft bright day. Along the wood's edge the wild azalea was out, the one they called the Pinkster flower because it kept that date, pink on bare grey stems before its own leaves came. Pinkster was the holiday the Dutch gave their Black people, three days of it, and already there were men and women on the road in their best, walking toward the green by Sleght's tavern where there would be a fiddle by noon. They stood aside for the wagon. Trijntje looked at each face as it went by.

The church was more than half full, which for the Dutch reading was a crowd. The Kroms had the fourth pew. Kees went up the stair to the gallery, where the people of his color sat on benches with no backs. Meester Brink stood at his desk under the pulpit in his rusty coat, opened the

clasps, and read them the second chapter of the Acts, the rushing wind and the tongues of fire, in a voice like a dry board.

And Trijntje listened. She had never in her life listened so hard to anything. She sat upright in the black silk with her hands folded on her book, and every word came to her small and clear, as if through a keyhole. *Every man heard them speak in his own language.* She heard that. She thought of the plank door and the barrel, and of how much noise a person could make with her hands and feet tied, and she heard that too.

IV. The Visit

The Krom farm · the same morning

Petrus Oosterhoudt was Trijntje's brother, and his wife Lena had fried olykoeks on Saturday, a whole crock of them, and said it was a shame to eat them alone on a holiday with a sister three miles off. They drove over from Hurley after an early breakfast, meaning to surprise her. They found the door on the latch, the way every door on the flats was, and nobody at home.

Gone to church, said Petrus. *On an off Sunday. My sister.*

Lena went down to the cellar kitchen to blow up the fire for coffee. The hearth was cold. She was on her knees with the bellows when she heard it, a slow knocking, like a shutter loose in a small wind, except that there was no wind. It came from behind the vinegar barrel.

It took the two of them to roll the barrel. Petrus opened the plank door and the light went in.

Lena had known Dina since the week she was born. She had held her at Bet's burying. She did not know her now for the space of a breath. Then she did, and she made a sound and got down on the bricks and began to pick at the knots, and Petrus cut them with his clasp knife, and they brought her out to the hearth.

Petrus was a farmer. He looked once at the ears and knew what he was looking at, the way he would have known it across a pasture. He said his sister's name, quietly, and went up the stairs, and Lena heard him walking in the yard.

She washed the face with warm water as well as she could and tied it round with a clean linen towel from the kas, under the chin and over the crown, the way they tie up the jaw of the dead. She was crying, and talking the whole time. *Lie down, child. Lie here. They will come home at noon and Petrus will speak to her. He will speak to Jacobus. This will be made right. It is a thing for the family. Nobody needs to know.*

Dina drank a dipper of water, and another. Her wrists were black where the linen had been.

Where are they?

At church. They must be.

Dina got up. She stood a moment with her hand on the chimney shelf until the room was steady. Then she went up the cellar stairs, past the fourth one, and out at the kitchen door.

You cannot go like that, Lena said behind her. *Dina. On Pinkster. Everyone will see.*

It was three miles by the King's road. She walked it in the middle of the track, in the dress she had been cut in, with the towel round her head. The Pinkster flower was out along the wood. The holiday people going down to the green met her and stopped, and stood aside as they had for the wagon. They looked at the towel, and the brown stain coming through it at both sides, and at her bare feet. A woman from the Roosa place asked her a question and got no answer. When Dina had gone by, the woman turned around and walked after her. Then a man did. By the time she passed the tavern there were eleven or twelve behind her, in their good clothes, and the fiddler stood in Sleght's doorway with the bow in his hand and did not play. Last of all, at a walk, came the Oosterhoudts' wagon. Petrus did not dare to pass her and could not make himself turn back.

V. The Aisle

The stone church · toward noon

THE MEESTER HAD FINISHED THE CHAPTER AND WAS FINDING the psalm when the door opened at the back and the light came up the aisle.

She did not take the gallery stair. She came up the middle of the church, past the pews with the names on the doors, as far as the open place under the pulpit where they set the table on communion Sundays, and there she turned around. The men were on her right hand and the women on her left. The elders and deacons sat in their bench along the wall. Over all of them was the gallery, where old Kees had got to his feet. The ones who had followed her stood in the door. So that she had the whole of that country in front of her, as it was sorted.

She undid the towel. It stuck, and she pulled it free.

Nobody in the stone church made any sound at all. She spoke in Dutch, and not loudly. The old people said afterward that they had heard every word in the last pew.

I am Dina. I was born of Bet in Jacobus Krom's cellar and I owe him ten months. This winter the baas came down the stairs to me at night. I did not ask him to. Yesterday the juffrouw tied my hands with her yarn and did this with the lamb knife, and put me in the root cellar behind the vinegar. Then she came here.

That was all. She stood with the towel in her hand.

The Meester had come around his desk. He was a small man and had to look up at her. He looked at the left ear, and then at the right, for some time, the way he would look at a page.

A crop off the left, he said, *and a slit in the right.*

He did not say whose. Half the men in the church had driven Krom sheep out of their corn. They turned and looked at the fourth pew.

The Meester went back behind his desk. People thought he would say something about the law, or send a boy for the justice. He stood with both hands on the Bible and looked at Trijntje Krom over the top of it, and when he spoke it was in his school voice, without heat.

You thought, nobody knows this that I have done. And you came and sat down here. Trijntje, if nobody had known it, to the end of your life, if she had died behind the barrel and you had buried her at night, it would still have been better never done. A thing like this does not stay where it is put. It burns afterward. I have seen it burn fifty years in people who were never found out.

Then he turned the heavy pages back from the Acts until he had the place, and read it to all of them.

> *Wee dengenen, die zich diep versteken willen voor den HEERE, hun raad verbergende; en welker werken in duisterheid geschieden, en zij zeggen: Wie ziet ons, en wie kent ons?*
>
> *Woe unto them that seek deep to hide their counsel from the LORD, and their works are in the dark, and they say, Who seeth us? and who knoweth us?*
>
> *— Jesaja (Isaiah) 29:15*

He turned again, forward this time, and did not have to hunt for it.

> *Die zijn overtredingen bedekt, zal niet voorspoedig zijn; maar die ze bekent en laat, zal barmhartigheid verkrijgen.*
>
> *He that covereth his sins shall not prosper: but whoso confesseth and forsaketh them shall have mercy.*
>
> *— Spreuken (Proverbs) 28:13*

Jacobus Krom stood up on the men's side. He was grey in the face. He held on to the pew door.

What she says of me is so, he said. *I went down. She never asked it.*

Trijntje had not moved. She sat with the psalm book shut in her lap and looked at what was standing under the pulpit. In the opkamer she had seen only a face that men looked at. She had cut at that. Now, in the plain light of the church windows, with the whole flats on either side of her, she saw a girl of twenty-four with her ears cut like a ewe's, holding a bloody towel. She saw that she had made it with her own hands, on her own bedroom floor, and that no scrubbing with sand would ever make it

not so. She looked for the anger that had carried her and could not find any of it. There was only the thing done, and herself, who had done it.

She stood. She had to try twice before the words would come.

It is so. All of it. And then, to the old man, in a voice nobody there had heard from her: *Meester, what can I do?*

You cannot put it back, he said. *That is what I have been telling you.* He opened the drawer of his desk and took out the ink bottle and a pen, and laid a clean sheet on the closed Bible. *But there is a thing left that is better done than not done. You know what the law lets you do. The overseers are sitting there.*

They were. Dirck Schoonmaker and Abram Keator, overseers of the poor for the town of Marbletown, were in the elders' bench in their Sunday black, and a justice of the peace was in the third pew on the men's side with his mouth open.

The Meester wrote it in English, because the law was English now. He wrote it standing, and it took him some time, and nobody left. *Know all men by these presents that I, Jacobus Krom of the Town of Marbletown in the County of Ulster, do hereby release, set free and discharge Dina, born of my woman Bet, from all and every kind of service to me, my heirs, executors and assigns, from this day.* Under it the two overseers certified that they had examined the said Dina and found her under the age of fifty years and of sufficient ability to provide for herself, which was the form. Abram Keator's hand shook so that he blotted it.

Jacobus signed. Trijntje came out of the pew and up the aisle and asked for the pen. The law did not want a wife's name and the Meester gave her the pen anyway. She signed under her husband, *Catrina Krom*, and then she turned to Dina, who was a head taller, and lifted her face and looked at the ears and the nose, at each of them, as she had not let herself look in the opkamer. She did not ask to be forgiven. She was a woman who counted, and she had seen what the count was.

The Meester sanded the sheet and shook it and held it out. Dina could not read it. She folded it in the towel.

VI. Whole Ears

Marbletown · 1826 and after

She did not go to the canal. She went that night to Lena Oosterhoudt's at Hurley, in the wagon, with the crock of olykoeks between her feet, and stayed until the cuts closed, and after that she worked for wages. She had four York shillings a week and her board from a widow at Stone Ridge, and she could leave on any day she chose, and she tried it once, to see, and came back on the Monday.

In September she stood up in the stone church at the communion season and was received on her confession, and the Meester wrote her into the church book. He asked what second name he should put. She had never had one. She said Bet's. So he wrote it the old way, as a child is written after a father: *Dina Bets, a free woman.* It was the third time he had written her down.

On the off Sundays that winter, after the reading, when the old people had gone home, she stayed. He taught her letters out of the States Bible. He began with her own name and went on from there, a line a week, his finger under the words, saying very little. She sat in the gallery no longer. She sat on the front bench on the women's side, with her cap pushed back off her ears, and no one ever asked her to pull it down. When the Meester died, in the hard winter of 1831, the consistory could find no man who still read Dutch well enough to stand at the desk. For two years after that, on the Sundays between, it was Dina Bets who opened the brass clasps and read the chapter to the last of the old people. They said she read it better than the dominie read English, and slower.

Old Kees went free on the Fourth of July, 1827, with all the rest, and walked to Kingston the same day to find a daughter.

Trijntje Krom never again missed the Dutch reading. She sat in the fourth pew every off Sunday for the nineteen years she had left, three benches behind the pushed-back cap, and people noticed that she listened as if through a keyhole. She still counted. But she was seen at the churchyard wall, more than once, on the far side, at the wood's edge, where Bet was. In May she brought the Pinkster flower there, and she

never said to anyone why. Jacobus did not go down the cellar stairs again for any reason. He had a door cut from the yard and went in that way.

• • •

The week after Pinkster, Jacobus Krom came to the Meester's house beside the school and asked for the old mark book. It was in the new clerk's keeping by then, and the new clerk said a mark could be sold or left to a son but he knew of no way to unwrite one. The Meester sent a boy for the book all the same. He found the page from 1798, with the little sheep's head he had drawn when he was young, the left ear cropped and the right one slit. He drew his pen through the entry once, and wrote the date in the margin, and blotted it.

The Krom lambs were not cut that spring, nor any spring after. They ran on the commons with the others, and in the fall, when the flocks were sorted, the men of Marbletown went through them ear by ear, the halfpennies and the swallow forks and the crops, and set aside what was left. Nobody was ever in doubt. A Krom sheep was the one with whole ears.

Background

The verse

> *An evil deed is better left undone, for a man repents of it afterwards; a good deed is better done, for having done it, one does not repent.*
>
> Dhammapada 314, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is one of the shortest in the collection. A woman of Sāvatthi learns that her husband has lain with a servant of the house. She binds the servant hand and foot, cuts off her nose and ears, shuts her in a hidden room, and then, to cover what she has done, takes her husband to the monastery to hear the teaching. Relatives come visiting, open the door and release the servant, who walks to the monastery and tells the Buddha what happened in front of the whole assembly. He says that no one should do even a small wrong thinking that others will not know, since a hidden deed still burns afterward, and speaks the verse. Husband and wife

are changed by it, free the servant on the spot, and she becomes a follower. Read the full commentary story.

Marbletown, New York

Ulster County, 1826

Slavery in New York ended slowly. A law of 1799 freed no one then living; it declared children born to enslaved mothers after July 4 of that year free, but bound them to serve the mother's master until twenty-five if female and twenty-eight if male, and required each birth to be reported to the town clerk. A second law in 1817 set July 4, 1827, as the day everyone born before 1799 would go free. Until then a master could manumit by a written paper, with the town's overseers of the poor certifying that the person was under fifty and able to support herself; the wording in the story follows surviving certificates. More on slavery in New York. Ulster County's farm country was among the last strongholds. Its slaveholders were largely "that class of people called Low Dutch," in the words of Sojourner Truth, who was born there about 1797, grew up speaking only Dutch, slept as a child in a slaveholder's cellar, and walked away from her last master in 1826. Pinkster, the Dutch Whitsuntide, was the great holiday of enslaved New Yorkers in the Hudson Valley, several days free of work. In 1826 it fell on May 14.

The voorlezer was the lay reader of a Dutch Reformed congregation, usually also its schoolmaster and often the keeper of the village records; when no minister was present he read the scripture and led the psalms. The title was fading by 1800 and Dutch preaching with it (New Paltz, nearby, went over wholly to English in 1817), though the language lingered in Hudson Valley kitchens for generations. The Dutch readings in the story, the church at the Steenkill and all its people are invented. The earmarks are not: New York towns kept registers of the cuts by which each farmer knew his sheep and hogs, entered in just such words as "a crop on the left ear and a slit in the same." The scripture is the Dutch States Bible (Statenvertaling) of 1637, with the King James Version beneath it.

After the story of the woman jealous by nature from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 314). The original. Scripture from the Dutch Statenvertaling (1637) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

22.7

Pipe Ash

> *So imprudent are we that we wander in the times which are not ours, and do not think of the only one which belongs to us.*
> *— Pascal, Pensées 172*

C'est comme ça que je l'ai entendu conter, on the River Raisin.

I. The Town Inside the Pickets

Detroit · May 1805

The four of them came up from the River Raisin at the end of April in a trader's bateau with forty bushels of seed wheat and a crate of hens, and the curé of Detroit, who had asked the curé at the Raisin for girls who could read, looked them over on the landing and nodded.

They were Marie-Louise Couture, who was seventeen and the oldest; Archange Duval, who was sixteen and laughed at everything; Thérèse Bourdeau, who was sixteen and laughed at nothing; and Félicité Jacob, who was fifteen, and whose mother had cried on the bank as if the bateau were going to France. All four had learned their letters at the same kitchen table on the river road below the Raisin, from the widow Laforêt, who had been to the Ursulines at Quebec when she was a girl, before the English came. Now they were to learn how to teach other children their letters, at the curé's academy for young ladies, and come home in the fall and do it.

Detroit was the largest place any of them had seen. It sat on its bank inside a fence of cedar pickets taller than a man, with gates that were shut at night, and inside the pickets the houses stood so close along the little streets that a woman on one gallery could hand a cup of sugar to a woman on the next. Above it, on the hill, was the old English fort with

the American flag on it. Below it was the river, a mile wide and green, and on the other side the English shore, where the same French families lived under King George and kept their own church.

They boarded with the Beaugrands on the Rue Sainte-Anne, in a house of squared logs with a loft. Madame Beaugrand had five children and a husband in the fur trade and a heart, the girls agreed, like a bread oven. She gave them the loft and a feather tick. She gave them white bread on weekdays, which they had at home only on feasts. She gave them whitefish from the river, and pea soup with salt pork, and in the last week of May the first wild strawberries from the côte, a bowl of them on the table at noon with cream poured over.

In the mornings they sat in a room behind the church with four girls of good Detroit families and copied out fair hands, and did sums, and learned to cut a quill, and sang. In the afternoons they sewed. In the evenings they walked out the gate with the Beaugrand children to look at the pear trees in blossom along the côte, the old French pears that had been planted, people said, when Cadillac came, and that were taller than the houses.

It was the best month of Archange's life, and she said so every night in the loft. Thérèse did not say so, but she ate her strawberries slowly.

The town had a law about fire, and Monsieur Beaugrand showed it to them, pleased with it, the way a man shows off a new gun. Every house had to keep its chimney swept. Every house had to keep a barrel of water full, and buckets, and a ladder long enough to reach the roof. The Beaugrands' ladder leaned against the back of the house, and their barrel stood under the eave with a skin of pollen on the water. Between the law and the pickets and the fort on the hill, Monsieur Beaugrand said, Detroit was as safe as any place on the lakes.

II. The Eleventh of June

Detroit · a Tuesday

It started a little after nine in the morning, in a stable. The girls were at their copybooks. Marie-Louise smelled it first and thought it was somebody's bread.

By the time they reached the street the stable was gone and the barn beside it was going, and the wind was up off the river, a dry hot June wind, and it took the burning hay out of the barn in pieces the size of a hand and laid them on the shingles of the houses all down the street, one roof and then the next and then the next, the way you lay out plates.

The men made a line from the river with buckets. The girls got into it. Marie-Louise stood between a Scotch merchant in a good coat and an old Panis woman who belonged to somebody, and passed the full buckets up and the empty ones down until her palms bled, and every bucket went up the line and was thrown at a roof and was nothing. Behind her somebody had pulled the Beaugrands' ladder down from the back wall and was carrying it toward the fire, and then had dropped it in the street and was running, and the ladder lay there and caught.

They went out the gate with what they could carry. Madame Beaugrand had the baby and the clock. Félicité had the feather tick. Archange, who could never afterward explain it, had the bowl the strawberries had been in. On the commons outside the pickets the whole town stood in the grass with its furniture around it, beds and kettles and chests of drawers and a spinning wheel, a crucifix, a cage with a jay in it, and watched the town burn inside its own fence.

The church burned. The pickets burned, a whole wall of them standing up in fire at once like a row of candles. By the middle of the afternoon there was nothing inside the line where the pickets had been but chimneys and smoke, and nothing left standing in Detroit but the fort on the hill and one warehouse by the water. No one had died. People kept saying it to each other on the commons, as if it were a thing you could put in your hand. *Nobody is dead. Nobody is dead.*

Toward evening the curé came out among them with his sleeves black to the elbow. He had men and boys going up and down the river in canoes, carrying bread and blankets to the families who had gone out to the farms, and he stood a while in the smoke looking at where his church had been, and said something in Latin that the girls did not understand, and went back to the canoes.

That night they slept in the grass of the commons with the Beaugrand children in a heap around them, and Marie-Louise lay on her back and watched the ash come down out of the dark, soft and gray, and settle on her face, and on Archange's face beside her, and on the strawberry bowl.

III. The Rest of the Summer

The côte above the ruins · June to August

WITHIN A WEEK EVERY FARMHOUSE FOR A LEAGUE UP THE river was full. The Beaugrands went into the house of a cousin above the town, eleven people in two rooms, and the four girls from the Raisin went into the cousin's hayloft.

Nobody had time for them. That was all it was. Nobody was unkind. The men were in the woods all day cutting new pickets and squaring logs, or in the ashes all day pulling out nails and hinges and the iron of stoves, or arguing at the top of their voices about whose lot had been where, because the stakes had burned. The women were cooking for twice as many people with half as many pots. At the beginning of July the new governor arrived with the judges and could not find a bed for a week, and after that there were surveyors in the ashes with chains, laying out streets that went every which way, wide as fields, and the men stopped cutting pickets to stand and shout at the surveyors. The academy did not meet. The room behind the church was not there.

The girls carried water. They minded the cousin's children and the Beaugrands' children together, which was nine children. They ate when the others had eaten, cold galette and whatever was left, and some nights nothing was left, and Madame Beaugrand, whose heart was still like a bread oven, did not notice, because she had not slept a whole night since

the eleventh of June. The mosquitoes came up off the river in the evenings. The hay in the loft was last year's and full of mice. Thérèse got a fever and got over it with nobody but the other three to sit with her.

Everybody on the côte had a story about how it started. It was a baker, people said, a man named Harvey, who had knocked out his pipe in his own stable against a post, the way a man does a thousand times, and the wind had done the rest. Others said no, it was set on purpose, by somebody with an interest in lumber. The governor himself was supposed to believe that. Monsieur Beaugrand believed it was the English. The girls heard every version a dozen times across the cousin's table, and the men who told them looked toward the river and the English shore when they said it, and toward the woods, and never toward the stable.

On the feast of the Assumption, the fifteenth of August, Marie-Louise came back from Mass with the other three and said they were going home.

IV. The Widow's Kitchen

The River Raisin · the end of August

They went down the river with the same trader who had brought them up, past the islands and the Wyandot town at Brownstown, and out along the low shore of Lake Erie where the marsh went on for miles with nothing in it but red-winged blackbirds, and turned in at the mouth of the Raisin, which wound back and forth so much that a man could walk across a bend in the time it took a boat to go round. They walked the last of it on the river road, under the orchards, with their bundles.

The widow Laforêt was in her kitchen, where she always was, at the end of a ribbon of land so narrow that her house took up most of the river end of it. She was seventy and small and brown as a walnut. She was sitting by her hearth in the summer evening with no fire in it but a few coals under the ash, smoking her short clay pipe, and she did not get up.

Well, she said. *Sit. Did it go well with you? Was it pleasant?*

They sat on the bench along the wall where they had sat with their slates when they were eight years old, and it all came out of them at once, the four of them talking over each other. The first month, the white bread, the strawberries, the pear trees, the copybooks. And then the fire. And then the hayloft and the mice and the nine children and the cold galette. How nobody had taught them anything after the eleventh of June, how they had not opened a book, how Thérèse had had a fever with nobody to sit with her, how the people of Detroit had had no time all summer for anything but their pickets and their lots and their quarrels.

The widow listened to all of it. When they were finished she took the pipe out of her mouth and leaned forward and knocked it out, three small knocks, on the hearthstone, inside the fire irons. Then she put her heel on the little heap of ash and turned it, back and forth, until it was gray powder. The girls had watched her do that their whole lives. There was a round place on the hearthstone, paler than the rest, where she had done it for fifty years.

Never mind, she said. *Don't take it to heart. A good bed is hard to come by, in any year, in any town. You were guests. Guests are fed when there is time.*

But there was never time, said Archange.

No. They were busy. She filled the pipe again from a bladder of tobacco, slowly, pressing it down with her thumb. *Tell me what they were busy with.*

Marie-Louise told her. The pickets. The new pickets, higher than the old ones. The lots, the stakes, the governor's streets. Watching the river. Watching the woods.

And where did the fire come from?

Nobody said anything. Thérèse, who laughed at nothing, looked at the round pale place on the hearthstone.

From a pipe, she said. *Inside the pickets. In a man's own stable.*

The widow lit her pipe with a coal held in the tongs and drew on it until it caught, and the bowl glowed and dimmed. Then she reached behind her to the shelf over the hearth, where she kept her salt and her rosary and one book, and took the book down. It was small and brown and the corners were soft as cloth. Her father had given it to her at Quebec. She opened it where it opened by itself and read to them, first in French, and

then, because Félicité's French was not good enough for Monsieur Pascal, slowly, in her own words.

> *I have discovered that all the unhappiness of men arises from one single fact, that they cannot stay quietly in their own chamber. A man who has enough to live on, if he knew how to stay with pleasure at home, would not leave it to go to sea or to besiege a town.*
>
> *— Pascal, Pensées 139*

So, said the widow. *Guard your town. All of it. The pickets, yes. And the stable.*

She turned some pages.

> *So imprudent are we that we wander in the times which are not ours, and do not think of the only one which belongs to us; and so idle are we that we dream of those times which are no more, and thoughtlessly overlook that which alone exists.*
>
> *— Pascal, Pensées 172*

You were in Detroit four months, she said, and closed the book. *For one of them you ate strawberries. For three of them you waited for somebody to give you your supper and your lessons. The people of Detroit had their whole town to build in one summer, and they built it. What did you build?*

She was not angry. She said it the way she had once told each of them, at eight years old, that the letter on her slate was backward.

The time that belongs to you is this one, she said. *It was the hayloft. It was nine children. Nine children, and four of you who know how to read.*

Archange began to laugh, and then stopped, and put her face in her hands.

They did not go home that night. They sat on the bench in the widow's kitchen with the door open to the river, and nobody said very much. The widow smoked. Toward midnight she knocked out her pipe, three knocks, inside the fire irons, and turned the ash under her heel, and drew the coals together and covered them, and went to bed. The four of them stayed on the bench in the dark. Something had come into the room that none of them could have named, and none of them wanted to be the first

to stand up and lose it. It was not a feeling. It was more like the moment after a bell, when the whole air has been rung and goes on being rung. Marie-Louise could hear the river going round its bends, and the frogs, and each of the other three breathing, and she knew without any doubt that this, the bench, the dark, the breathing, was the only time she would ever have, and that it was enough, and that she had nearly let a whole summer of it go by her while she waited for supper.

In the morning they walked to their mothers' houses. In October they went back up the river.

• • •

The next summer the militia at the Raisin built a stockade of their own, two hundred feet on a side, with a blockhouse, and everybody on the river road helped cut the pickets. By then Marie-Louise Couture was teaching twenty-two children their letters in a rented room in the new Detroit, at the corner of two of the governor's streets, and Thérèse was teaching in the room next to her, and there was a law in that school, which they had made themselves and wrote on the wall in a fair hand, that nobody, not the curé, not the governor, not the children's fathers when they came to fetch them, knocked out a pipe anywhere in that house but on the hearthstone, inside the irons. Most of them laughed. They did it anyway.

At night, after the children had gone, Marie-Louise went round the two rooms with a candle the way the widow went round her kitchen, and drew the coals together and covered them, and stood a moment in the dark with her hand on the warm stone, before she went up.

Background

The verse

> *Like a well-guarded frontier fort, with defences within and without, so let a man guard himself. Not a moment should escape, for they who allow the right moment to pass, suffer pain when they are in hell.*
>
> Dhammapada 315, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a company of monks spends the rains retreat in a village on the frontier. The first month is pleasant. In the second, bandits raid the village and carry some of its people off, and from then on the villagers are so busy strengthening their town that they have no time to look after their guests, who pass the rest of the retreat in discomfort. Afterward the monks go back to the Buddha at Jetavana and tell him how hard it was. He tells them not to be troubled, since a comfortable lodging is hard to find at any time, and that a monk should guard himself as those villagers guarded their town, inside and out, and not let the moment pass. Hearing the verse, the monks are moved to urgency and reach awakening. Read the full commentary story, or about the rains retreat (vassa).

The widow's book is Blaise Pascal's *Pensées*, quoted here in the English translation by W. F. Trotter (1910).

Detroit, Michigan Territory

Detroit, 1805

In 1805 Detroit was a town of a few hundred people, most of them French-speaking, packed into a few acres of log and frame houses inside a timber stockade on the river, with the old British-built Fort Lernoult on the rise behind. A town ordinance of 1802 required every household to sweep its chimneys and to keep a barrel of water, buckets and a ladder. On the morning of June 11, 1805, a fire began in or near the stable of a baker named John Harvey (the story that he knocked out his pipe there

has never been proved), and by afternoon the whole town was gone except the fort and a warehouse. No one died. Michigan Territory's new governor, William Hull, arrived on July 1 and wrote that every house was crowded and that he needed more than a week to find a place to stay. Judge Augustus Woodward laid out a new town of wide radiating avenues. See the Great Fire of 1805 and the Detroit Historical Society's account.

The pastor of Ste. Anne's, the Sulpician Gabriel Richard, had opened an academy for young ladies in 1804 to train teachers for the schools he planned; after the fire he sent canoes up and down the river with food and blankets for the burned-out families. His words in the ashes, *Speramus meliora; resurget cineribus* ("We hope for better things; it will rise from the ashes"), became the city's motto. Forty miles south, French families from Detroit had settled the River Raisin from 1785 on long narrow "ribbon farms" running back from the water; in 1806 the militia there built a stockade with a blockhouse. See Frenchtown at River Raisin National Battlefield Park.

After the story of a company of monks from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 315). The original. Quotations from Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*, translated by W. F. Trotter (Harvard Classics, 1910). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.8

The Flea-Glass

> *The number of these Animals in the scurf of a mans Teeth, are so many that I believe they exceed the number of Men in a kingdom.*
> *— Leeuwenhoek, Philosophical Transactions 14 (1684)*

As I have heard it reported, in the North End of Boston.

I. The Sign of the Quadrant

Ann Street, Boston · summer 1721

Silas Crane had made quadrants and compasses and spectacles at the sign of the gilt quadrant in Ann Street for twenty-six years, and when he died of a quinsy in the winter of 1719 his widow took down nothing but his hat from its peg. She kept the shop. She kept his two apprentices, whose indentures had four years and six years to run, and she kept the trade, because she had been grinding his lenses for him since the year they married, and anybody on the Long Wharf who had bought a pair of Crane spectacles since 1700 had been looking through her work.

Mistress Crane was fifty-eight, tall, with large red hands from the tripoli and the water. She said very little. When a ship's master came in with a compass whose card stuck, she took it from him, and opened it, and fixed it, and told him the price, and that was the conversation. The apprentices, Josiah Pratt and Eben Mayhew, who were sixteen and fourteen, had decided she did not like them, and then decided she did not like anybody, and then, after a year, had stopped deciding anything about her and simply watched her hands.

On the shelf behind the counter, in a case lined with green baize, she kept her husband's flea-glass. It was a brass plate the size of a playing card with a bead of glass no bigger than a mustard seed set in a hole in the middle, and a pin on a screw to hold the thing you looked at. Mr. Crane had made it himself, after the description of the Dutchman at Delft, and he had kept two books beside it, Mr. Hooke's great folio with the plates and an odd volume of the Royal Society's Transactions. On a slow afternoon Mistress Crane would sometimes take it down and set a drop of rainwater on the pin and hold it up to the window and look for a long time, and then put it away again without a word.

The boys of the street knew about the glass. Every boy in the North End had been in the shop at one time or another to have a flea or a hair or a bit of cheese mite put on the pin, and had looked, and yelled. It cost a penny. Mistress Crane took the penny.

The smallpox came off the *Seahorse* from Barbados in April, and by June it was in the town, and by the end of June Dr. Boylston had done the thing that made half of Boston want to hang him: he had taken matter from a pox sore and put it into a cut in his own little boy's arm, and into the arms of two of the Africans of his household, on purpose, so they would take the pox lightly and be done with it. All three lived. Mr. Mather, the minister of the North meeting, had put him up to it, people said, and Mr. Mather had got it from an African too.

Next door to the Crane shop, in a yard full of staves and hoops, worked a free cooper called Peter Coffee, who had been born on the Gold Coast and brought to Boston as a boy. In July, in front of Josiah and Eben, a carter asked him whether it was true, what they said about the Africans and the pox. Peter Coffee pushed up his sleeve and showed them a small pale scar on the outside of his arm.

My mother did that, he said. *With a thorn. I was smaller than him.* He nodded at Eben.

The boys laughed. Afterward Josiah could not have said why. The carter laughed first.

II. The French Ladies

Middle Street · September

By September the town was emptying of anybody who had somewhere to go,. The General Court had gone to Cambridge. In the evenings men stood about at the head of the Long Wharf and argued about Boylston, and once a crowd went to a house in Middle Street where a man was lying sick of the inoculation and stood outside throwing stones and calling him a murderer until the constable came, and Josiah and Eben were in the crowd, at the back, and threw two stones each. They told nobody at the shop. Mistress Crane did not ask where they had been.

It was on Middle Street, a week after, that they met the Pelletreau sisters.

Everybody knew the three Mesdemoiselles Pelletreau, who had come from La Rochelle by way of London as girls, after the King of France took away the Protestants' churches, and who kept a school for young ladies in two rooms over a chandler's, French and needlework and the use of the globes. They went to the French church. They were small, upright, and old. And now, in the middle of the pox, they went about the town with fine linen tied over their mouths and noses, like the ladies in pictures of Turkey, and the eldest carried a little covered cup when she went to buy milk, with a saucer on the top of it.

There, Eben said, when they had passed. *There's decent women. Not like the fishwives on the wharf, bawling with their mouths open and spitting in the street.*

It's fear, said Josiah. *They're afraid of the pox. They think it comes in at the mouth.*

Well, it's modest, anyhow. They're ashamed to be seen, at their age, and they cover up. Good for them.

The eldest Mademoiselle Pelletreau stopped in the street and turned round. She had very good ears.

It is not for shame, she said, through the linen. *And it is not for fear. We are too old for the pox to want us, and we have seen it before, in London. It is for the little animals.*

The boys looked at each other.

She explained. Two years ago, she said, they had come to Mistress Crane's shop and paid a penny each to look through the glass, as everybody did, at a drop of water from their own rain barrel, and they had seen it. The water was alive. It was full of creatures, swimming and turning, more than you could count, too small to see, every one of them made by God the same as a horse is made, and since that day they could not drink a cup of water without thinking of what they drank, or breathe the air without thinking of what might be in it. So they covered their cups, and they covered their mouths, so as not to swallow the little animals and kill them for nothing.

For nothing? said Josiah.

Everything God made has its life, said the second sister. *Even what you cannot see. Why should we take it?*

Then it went on for a long time, there in Middle Street, in the smell of smoke and vinegar from the doorways where people burned things to clean the air. Josiah said she would have to stop drinking altogether, then, and stop breathing, and the eldest said they boiled their water and strained it through a cloth, and Eben said then she was killing them by boiling instead of by drinking, and the youngest sister said that was a different thing, and Josiah said how, and nobody could say how. A carter stopped to listen. A girl with a basket of eggs stopped. The argument went round and round and arrived nowhere, and at last the eldest Mademoiselle Pelletreau said that the young men should ask Mistress Crane, who had the glass, and the boys said they would, and everybody went away certain he had won.

III. The Glass

Ann Street · the same evening

Mistress Crane was at the wheel, grinding, when they told her. She did not stop until they had finished. Then she wiped her hands, and took the flea-glass down from the shelf, and took a clean goose quill from the jar.

Open your mouth, she said to Josiah.

She scraped between two of his back teeth with the point of the quill and took off a little white stuff, like wetted flour. She mixed it on a slip of glass with a drop from the rain jar and touched the pin to it and gave him the brass plate and turned him to the window.

He looked for a long time. Then he gave it to Eben, and Eben looked, and put the glass down on the counter very carefully, as if it might go off.

It was alive. The little white stuff from between his teeth was a whole town. There were long ones that shot through the water like pickerel. There were round ones that spun like tops. There were small ones beyond counting that swarmed and turned among each other like gnats over a pond in the evening. Mistress Crane took down the odd volume of the Transactions and opened it to a page she had marked with a strip of leather, and put her red finger on a line, and Josiah read it out.

> *The number of these Animals in the scurf of a mans Teeth, are so many that I believe they exceed the number of Men in a kingdom.*
>
> *— Leeuwenhoek, Philosophical Transactions 14 (1684)*

Then she took the vinegar cruet from the shelf where they kept their dinner things and let one drop fall into the water on the glass, and gave it back to Josiah, and he looked, and they were all lying still.

You had vinegar on your fish at noon, she said. *And you breathed all day. And you walked to Middle Street on a few thousand of them.*

That was all she said about the Pelletreau sisters. She did not say they were fools. She put a fresh drop of rainwater on the pin and looked into it herself a while, the way she did on slow afternoons.

Then she said, without looking up, *Eben, come here,* and when he came she put her big hand on his head and went through his hair with her fingers as quick as a mother, and found what she was looking for, and put it on the pin, and handed him the glass.

He looked, and made a sound, and Josiah took it from him.

It filled the whole glass. It was gray and clear as horn and you could see the blood inside it, Eben's blood, moving. It had six legs with hooks on the ends of them, and a head like a cone, and two black eyes that looked backward.

Mistress Crane had Mr. Hooke's folio open on the counter by then, at the great folding plate of the louse, and she read it to them herself. It was the longest speech either of them ever heard her make.

> *This is a Creature so officious, that 'twill be known to every one at one time or other, so busie, and so impudent, that it will be intruding it self in every ones company, and so proud and aspiring withall, that it fears not to trample on the best, and affects nothing so much as a Crown; feeds and lives very high, and that makes it so saucy, as to pull any one by the ears that comes in its way, and will never be quiet till it has drawn blood: it is troubled at nothing so much as at a man that scratches his head, as knowing that man is plotting and contriving some mischief against it...*
>
> *— Robert Hooke, Micrographia (1665), Observation 54*

She closed the book.

Not ashamed of anything it ought to be, she said. *Afraid of the one thing that can't hurt it. It's a good likeness.*

Eben scratched his head, and then stopped, and went red.

The ladies are ashamed of nothing, if you want to know, she said. *They don't cover their mouths for shame. They're afraid of killing what they kill anyway with every breath, and that's their business, and it's a kind fault. But the two of you.* She looked at them, one and then the other, and the boys found that she knew about Middle Street, and the stones, and had always known. *You're afraid of a scratch on a child's arm. You're not afraid of the pox, that's in every third house. You're not afraid to stand in a crowd of two hundred breath-*

ing on each other to throw stones at a sick man. You're ashamed to be seen talking to Peter Coffee. You're not ashamed of what you did in Middle Street.

She put the louse into the fire.

That's backward, she said. *It's a bad road, backward. It ends somewhere you won't like.*

Then she went back to the wheel, and they heard the tripoli whispering on the brass, and the water dripping into the trough, the way it did every evening.

IV. Going Forth

Ann Street and Middle Street · October and after

In October more than four hundred people died in Boston, the worst month, and on the twenty-sixth, the day of Thanksgiving, every meeting in the town held one sermon only, at eleven in the morning, so as not to crowd the people twice. Mistress Crane went. The boys went with her and sat by the door.

Josiah went to the cooper's yard the next day, and stood about among the staves until Peter Coffee looked up, and asked him how his mother had done it, with the thorn. Peter Coffee told him, while he drove a hoop. Then he showed Josiah how you set the hoop driver so it doesn't slip, which Josiah had not asked.

In November, in the middle of the night, somebody threw a lighted grenado through the window of Mr. Mather's house, where his nephew was lying sick of the inoculation, with a note tied to it, and it did not go off. All the town talked about the note. Eben, who would have laughed in the summer, did not laugh. He said only that whoever had done it was not afraid of the right thing, and Josiah knew where he had got it.

The Pelletreau sisters came to the shop the week after the grenado. They had heard, as everybody heard everything, about the quill and the vinegar. The eldest asked whether it was true, what was between the young men's teeth, and Mistress Crane said she could see for herself for a penny, and the eldest put down three pennies, and the three of them

looked at the inside of their own mouths, one after another, by the window, a long time.

When they came out of the shop the linen was folded in the eldest sister's reticule. They came back the next week, and the week after, not to look but to learn the wheel, because the second sister had said that if the world was going to be full of things too small to see, somebody ought to be able to make the glass to see them, and it might as well be a woman, since Mistress Crane was. The town found that very French. All that winter, until the pox was gone out of Boston, the Mesdemoiselles Pelletreau went with their school girls from house to house of the sick with broth, bare-faced, and nobody could say afterward that any of them had taken it.

• • •

Josiah Pratt finished his time and kept the shop at the sign of the quadrant after her, and made spectacles for half the captains in Boston, and when boys came in with a penny he still put a flea on the pin for them, and let them yell. But if one of them was old enough, and wanted to see something more, he would take a clean quill out of the jar.

Open your mouth, he would say.

Background

The verses

> *They who are ashamed of what they ought not to be ashamed of, and are not ashamed of what they ought to be ashamed of, such men, embracing false doctrines enter the evil path.*
>
> Dhammapada 316, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *They who fear when they ought not to fear, and fear not when they ought to fear, such men, embracing false doctrines, enter the evil path.*
>
> Dhammapada 317, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, some monks see a group of Nigaṇṭhas, the Jain ascetics, who wear a small covering in front, and decide they must be more modest than the ascet-

ics who go entirely naked. The Niganṭhas overhear and correct them: the covering is not for modesty at all. Even dust is alive, they say, and the cloth keeps living things from falling into their alms bowls. A long argument follows. When the monks report it, the Buddha says that those who feel shame where there is nothing shameful, and none where there is, and who fear what is not to be feared and do not fear what is, are on a bad road; and many of the Niganṭhas go forth after hearing him. Read the full commentary story, or about Jainism and its care for the smallest forms of life.

The widow's books are Robert Hooke's *Micrographia* (1665), whose great plate of the louse astonished its readers, and the Royal Society's *Philosophical Transactions*, which in 1684 printed in English an abstract of Antonie van Leeuwenhoek's letter describing the "Animals in the scurf of the Teeth." Leeuwenhoek's microscopes were single beads of glass mounted in small brass plates; in English, simple magnifiers of this kind were often called flea-glasses.

Boston, Massachusetts Bay

Boston, 1721

Smallpox reached Boston on the *Seahorse* from Barbados on April 22, 1721. Before the epidemic ended the next February, about 5,800 of the town's roughly 10,600 people had caught it and 844 had died, with October the worst month. Cotton Mather had learned of inoculation years earlier from Onesimus, an enslaved West African man in his household, and from reports from Constantinople; on June 26 Dr. Zabdiel Boylston inoculated his own six-year-old son and two enslaved members of his household, all of whom survived. Most of the town's physicians, led by William Douglass, and James Franklin's new *New-England Courant* attacked the practice. Crowds forced inoculated people out to the quarantine house on Spectacle Island, and in November someone threw a homemade bomb into the room in Mather's house where his inoculated nephew was recovering; it failed to explode. About two percent of the inoculated died, against roughly fifteen percent of those who caught the disease naturally. See the 1721 Boston smallpox outbreak and Onesimus.

Boston's French Protestant church had been gathered by Huguenot refugees in the 1680s, after Louis XIV revoked the Edict of Nantes in 1685 and outlawed Protestant worship in France. Many of the refugees came, like the Pelletreau sisters, by way of London. See the Huguenots.

After the story of the Niganṭhas from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 316–317). The original. Quotations from Robert Hooke, *Micrographia* (1665), and from Antonie van Leeuwenhoek's letter of September 17, 1683, as abstracted in the *Philosophical Transactions* of the Royal Society, vol. 14 (1684). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

22.9

Jelly Glasses

Woe unto them that call evil good, and good evil.
— Isaiah 5:20

The way I heard it told, on Lorman Street.

I. The Bible on the Table

Lorman Street, West Baltimore · June 1974

Raymond Purnell had been baptized at Mount Hebron Baptist at the age of nine, in the same pool and on the same Sunday as Earl Pettiford, and for that reason the Pettifords took it harder than anybody when he came home from the Army with a new religion. He was thirty now. He drove a city bus on the split shift and lived alone at 1614 in the house his mother had left him. Twice a day, at six in the morning and again when he got in at night, the block could hear him through the front window. He said the same six syllables over and over, fast, in a strong flat voice, and then a long rattle of something that was not English, and every so often he struck a bell.

He had got it at Fort Meade in 1968, after Vietnam. His first sergeant's wife was a Japanese lady from Yokohama, and she asked every soldier who came to the house whether he was happy, and waited for a true answer, and then drove him to a meeting. Raymond had gone to be polite. On Tuesday nights now there were fifteen or twenty people in his front room, and they called him the district chief.

The Pettifords had no quarrel with his manners. He scrubbed his marble steps on Saturday like everyone else and spoke to every person he passed. But Dorothy Pettiford had seen the young people from that religion downtown on Howard Street, stopping strangers with a smile and

steering them by the elbow toward a parked car, and she had heard that the thing they bowed to was a piece of paper in a box. That spring her Tyrone, who was eleven, and her Sheila, who was eight, had been playing every afternoon with Kevin Tubbs, whose mother went to the Tuesday meetings. So had the Boone twins from 1609, and the three Goins children from the corner.

The week school let out, Earl Pettiford set the family Bible on the kitchen table and had Tyrone and Sheila put their hands on it. They could say good afternoon to Mr. Purnell, because they had been raised right. They were not to say anything more to him than that. They were not to set one foot inside 1614, not the vestibule, not for any reason. *Say it,* he told them, and they said it. Mrs. Boone heard what the Pettifords had done and did the same with the twins that night, and the Goins children were sworn by their grandmother on Sunday, in their church clothes.

II. Water

July 1974

The first of July the men who picked up the city's trash went out on strike, and inside of a week the alleys of West Baltimore were head high in it. People set the piles on fire at night. Children who had always played out back were told to stay on the front street, where there was no shade.

The second Tuesday of the strike it was past ninety by noon. Eight children were playing stepball against the Boones' front steps, and by two o'clock nobody was running for the ball. The corner store was shut. The city had capped the hydrant. The Pettifords and the Boones were at work and their doors were locked until five, and the Goins children's grandmother was asleep in front of her fan and had told them what would happen to the one who woke her.

Mr. Purnell's front door stood open behind its screen. He was home between shifts.

Kevin, Tyrone said. *You can go in there. Go ask him for some water and bring it out to us.*

Kevin went up the steps and in. He was gone a few minutes. He came back out with his chin wet and nothing in his hands.

He said drink mine first, and I did. He said tell the rest of you come get your own. He said he's not sending his good glasses down those marble steps with a nine-year-old.

Nobody moved. Tyrone looked at his own front door across the street. Then Sheila got up off the curb and climbed the steps of 1614, and Tyrone went after her, as he would tell his father, to bring her back. The twins went after Tyrone, and the Goins children came last.

The front room was dim and cooler than the street. A fan turned in the corner. Mr. Purnell had seven jelly glasses lined up on the mantel shelf, the kind with the Flintstones on them, worn half away, and a pitcher that had been in the icebox. He filled each glass and handed it to a child by name. He knew all their names. He filled them a second time without being asked.

Against the far wall stood a black cabinet with its doors open. Inside it hung a scroll of white paper covered with dark writing, large in the middle and small at the edges. There were two candles and some green leaves in a vase. A brass bowl the size of a mixing bowl sat on a cushion, and a small cup of water stood in front of everything.

You give it water too? Sheila asked.

Every morning. First glass of the day goes there.

What's it say? said Tyrone. He had not meant to speak.

Mr. Purnell sat down on the floor so that he was no taller than they were.

It says you, he said. *Top to bottom. Everything a person has got in him is written on there. The part that fights is on it, and the part that's scared, and the part that would give away his last dollar. Right down the middle, in the biggest letters, is the best you could be. It's a mirror for what the bathroom mirror can't get. I sit in front of it and say what's written down the middle until I can see it.*

He told them there were three rules in that room, and they were for him as much as for company. Nobody gets hurt in here. Nobody takes what isn't his. Nobody says what isn't so. He asked whether they could

keep those for as long as it took to drink a glass of water, and they said they could.

Then, because Sheila asked, he let each of them strike the bowl once with the padded stick. The sound stood in the room a long time after each one. He said the six syllables slowly, three times, with his hands together, and seven of the eight children said them with him. Tyrone said them the third time.

Whatever went into those children with the water did not come out again. A good many people tried to get it out.

III. Church Clothes

July 1974

Sheila told it at supper. She told all of it, the glasses and the cup of water for the scroll and the bell and the three rules, and then she put her hands together over her plate and said the six syllables to show how it went.

Dorothy Pettiford set down the serving spoon and wept. She wept as she had not done since her own mother's funeral. Earl went out and stood on his front steps with his arms folded and looked at 1614 until it was dark. Down the block Mrs. Boone could be heard through two walls. *My babies. In front of an idol. With their hands on the Book not three weeks ago.*

Mother Lucille Hazzard came across the street at eight o'clock with Mr. Deems the barber behind her. She was eighty-one, a deaconess of Mount Hebron, and she had taught the nine-year-olds' Sunday school class for forty years, Earl and Dorothy and Raymond Purnell among them. She took the kitchen chair that was offered and waited for Dorothy to finish.

I went in that house in 1970 to pray the devil out of it, she said. *I stayed for coffee. I have been watching that boy four years since, looking for the wrong in it, and I am a patient woman. Who drove Mr. Tubbs to the kidney machine three days a week till he died? Whose Buick has been hauling this block's garbage to the dump since the first of the month, with the windows down? He*

doesn't drink. He doesn't run women through his mother's house. He told your children not to hit, not to steal and not to lie, Dorothy, and gave them ice water. You cry over that if you want to. I am too old.

Mr. Deems said that Raymond had sat in his chair every other Friday for six years and had never once tried to sell him anything. He said he had been waiting for it.

They talked until past eleven. At the end of it Earl Pettiford said that if his children were going to be in that house, they were not going to sneak. He would put them there himself, in the daylight, and see what it was.

So on Sunday afternoon, after church and still in their church clothes, the Pettifords crossed Lorman Street with Tyrone and Sheila between them. The Boones came with the twins and Mrs. Boone's sister from Edmondson Avenue. The Goins children's grandmother came in her hat, and two uncles, and Mother Hazzard on Mr. Deems's arm. There were nineteen of them in Raymond Purnell's front room, and not enough chairs. He brought the ones from the kitchen. He did not look surprised.

Mother Hazzard gave me a verse in the basement of Mount Hebron when I was nine, he said, *and I never gave it back.*

> *Woe unto them that call evil good, and good evil; that put darkness for light, and light for darkness; that put bitter for sweet, and sweet for bitter!*
>
> — Isaiah 5:20

I have been on both ends of that. I called a bad thing good for thirteen months in a place I won't describe in front of children, and when I got home I called every good thing on this street by a bad name. That is where a person ends up who names a thing before he looks at it. I don't ask you to call this good. I ask you to look first. She gave me another one the year after.

> *But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age, even those who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil.*
>
> — Hebrews 5:14

By reason of use. That's all I do in here. Twice a day I use it, so I can tell the one from the other when I go out that door. It's near time for the evening one. You are welcome to sit and watch me, and then call it what it is.

He turned around and knelt and struck the bell, and nineteen people in church clothes watched him do it for twenty-five minutes.

• • •

The Pettifords kept their pew at Mount Hebron for the rest of their lives. They also let it be known that their children could go up the steps of 1614 whenever the screen door was open, and stay to listen on Tuesdays if their homework was done. Tyrone and Sheila went every week. Mrs. Boone began sitting in the back of the room in August, to keep an eye on the twins she said, and by Thanksgiving there was a black cabinet in her own front room. The Goins children's grandmother got hers at Easter. Dorothy Pettiford never said the six syllables once, and every Tuesday she sent Sheila across with something under a dish towel.

The men went back to the trucks in the middle of July and the alleys were cleared by August. Mr. Purnell never did put the jelly glasses back in the kitchen cabinet. They stood upside down on a folded towel at the end of the mantel shelf, seven and then an eighth he found to match, where a child could reach one without asking.

Background

The verses

> *They who forbid when there is nothing to be forbidden, and forbid not when there is something to be forbidden, such men, embracing false doctrines, enter the evil path.*
>
> Dhammapada 318, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *They who know what is forbidden as forbidden, and what is not forbidden as not forbidden, such men, embracing the true doctrine, enter the good path.*
>
> Dhammapada 319, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, parents who follow other teachers see their children playing with the children of the Buddha's lay followers. They forbid them to greet the monks

or enter the monastery and make them swear to it. One hot day the children are playing outside the monastery gate and grow thirsty, and they send in the one boy who is allowed to go, to bring water out. The Buddha has him drink and then call the others in for theirs, and when they have all drunk he teaches them something suited to their age. The children tell their parents everything, and the parents weep that their sons have gone over to a false faith. Sensible neighbors talk them round, and the parents bring the children to the monastery themselves, with all their relations. The Buddha speaks the two verses about seeing fault where there is none. Read the full commentary story.

West Baltimore, Maryland

West Baltimore, 1974

The Soka Gakkai, a Japanese lay movement in the tradition of the thirteenth-century priest Nichiren, reached the United States largely through Japanese women who had married American servicemen. Under the name Nichiren Shoshu of America it grew quickly in the 1960s and 1970s, and a large share of its American members were Black or Latino. Its practice is the chanting of Nam-myoho-renge-kyo, the title of the Lotus Sutra, morning and evening before a scroll called the Gohonzon, together with neighborhood meetings in members' homes. In those years it also recruited hard, on street corners and among strangers, which is the thing Dorothy Pettiford saw on Howard Street. Raymond Purnell, Mount Hebron Baptist and the families of the block are invented.

The Baltimore municipal strike of 1974 began with the city's trash collectors at the start of July and lasted two weeks. Garbage piled up in the alleys in the July heat, piles were set alight at night, and for several days much of the police force walked out as well. The white marble steps of the city's rowhouses, scrubbed by hand every week, were a point of pride in Sandtown as everywhere else in Baltimore.

After the story of the sectarian disciples from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 318–319). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 23

The Elephant

23.1

Ask On, My Son

"Ask on, my son," said Hillel.
— Shabbath 31a

Assim ouvi contar, on the Strand at New Amsterdam.

I. The Bark

New Amsterdam · September 1654

They came in on the Sainte Catherine at the beginning of September, twenty-three of them, four men and six women and thirteen children, out of Recife by way of the Spanish and the sea. The Portuguese had taken Recife back in January, and the Jews of Recife had been given three months to sell what they could and go. Most went home to Amsterdam. This boatload had been blown off its course, robbed by Spaniards as the story went, and picked up at Cape San Antonio by a French master named de la Motthe, who agreed to carry them to New Netherland for two thousand five hundred guilders, which they did not have.

He sued them in the burgomasters' court within the week. The court held their beds and chests and kettles against the debt and gave them forty-eight hours to pay. In the third week of September the Director-General, Stuyvesant, wrote home to the West India Company that he had told them to go, on account of their customary usury and deceitful trading with the Christians, and because they were poor and would be a charge on the deacons all winter.

They did not go. There was nowhere to go before spring, and the ice.

The oldest of them was Elias Valverde, who was seventy. He had been born in Porto with a Christian name, had come to Amsterdam as a boy

when his father fled the Inquisition, and had learned there, in the Jewish school by the Houtgracht, the Hebrew that his grandfathers had been burned for. In 1638 he went out to Recife, under the Dutch, and for sixteen years he had taught the boys of Kahal Zur Israel to read. He had buried his wife there and both his sons. He came into New Amsterdam with his grandnephew Daniel, who was nineteen, a bundle of books in a tarred cloth, and a coat.

He was a small man, very upright, with a white beard cut square. He said little. In the evenings, in the back room on the Brugh Straat they rented from a ship's carpenter, he read aloud to the children of the twenty-three, and they sat around him on the floor in a ring.

II. The Tapster's Widow

The Strand · winter 1655

THERE WAS A WOMAN ON THE STRAND WHO KNEW HIM.

Her name was Margriet Claes, and she kept the tap-house by the Company's warehouse, where the sailors drank, and she had done well by it. She had been born in Recife too, the daughter of a Company sugar factor, and when she was sixteen and very handsome her father had gone to Elias Valverde, whose elder son was then twenty, and offered her. The boy could be baptized, the factor said. There would be a good dowry. A man of sense did not let a thing like that go by for a few old prayers.

Valverde had answered him in front of the whole counting-house. The words got round Recife by evening, in Dutch and Portuguese both, and the girl heard them from her maid. He had said that his son was not to be had for a font and a pretty face, and that a face was skin over a skull, the same as his own, and would be a skull again soon enough.

She married a ship's mate instead, and buried him, and came north. Now Elias Valverde had come in on a French bark with his bed sold out from under him, a beggar in her town.

She did not do anything herself. She put stuivers into the hands of the boys who swept out the tap-house, and of sailors who owed her for their drink, and of two of the Company's negroes who carried casks for her at

the warehouse, and she told them where the old Jew walked in the mornings.

III. The Heerestraat

New Amsterdam · March 1655

He walked every morning from the Brugh Straat up the Heerestraat toward the land gate and back, because he had walked every morning in Recife and in Amsterdam before that, and an old man who stops walking stops.

At the end of February they began to follow him. A pack of boys first, and then grown men behind the boys, and then whoever was on the street and liked the sport. They walked behind him and beside him and shouted at him all the way to the gate and all the way back.

Thief. Fool. Usurer. Ox. Ass. Beast. You killed our Lord. You have no hope. Hell is waiting for you, old man, and all your people. One of them threw a fish head that struck him on the back of the neck. A sailor walked in front of him backward for a hundred paces with his breeches down. Women laughed in the doorways. The two Company men walked behind with the casks on their shoulders, and when the boys looked back at them for the next word they gave it, in a Dutch they had been taught for the purpose. On the third day Daniel went with him, and by the fifth Daniel was shaking.

They had come as far as the brewer's horse mill, where the street opened, when Daniel stopped him by the sleeve.

Uncle, let us go from here.

Where would we go?

Curaçao. There are Jews in Curaçao.

And if they shout at us in Curaçao?

Barbados, then.

And in Barbados?

Amsterdam. Anywhere. Uncle, they will kill you here.

Valverde stood in the street with the fish scale still on his collar and looked at the boy for a long time.

We came from Recife, he said. *Before that I came from Porto. My father came from Lisbon, and his grandfather from Toledo. Every one of them said, let us go from here. Where the trouble is, Daniel, there it has to be finished. When it is finished you may go where you like. Who is it that shouts at us?*

Everyone, said Daniel. *The boys. The sailors. The women. Even the Company's slaves.*

The old man was quiet. Then he told Daniel about the elephant.

IV. The Elephant

The Heerestraat · the same morning

When he was a man of fifty, he said, still in Amsterdam, they brought an elephant to the city from the Indies, a cow elephant called Hansken, and showed her at the fair. He had gone to see her with his sons, who were boys. She could wave a flag and fire a pistol and beat a drum, and take a coin out of a man's pocket with her nose and give it to her keeper.

They led her through the crowd at the fair, he said, from one booth to the next, through thousands of people. Boys pricked her with sticks. Men threw things to see her start. Somebody put a lit pipe to her ear. She did not start. She went where she was led, through all of it, with all of it falling on her from every side, and did what she had been taught to do. That was why they could lead her into a crowd. The Prince of Orange had sent for her, and a prince could have sat on her back.

So, said Valverde. *It is my part now to be the elephant. Most people are not good. They will shout. I will go where I am going.*

Behind them the brewer's horse went round and round inside the mill, blindfolded, turning the stone.

The horse is good because somebody trained it, he said. *The elephant also. But a man has to be trained by somebody too, and there is only himself to do it, and that is better than the horse.*

Then he told the boy the story of Hillel and the man who laid the wager, as he had told it to the boys of Recife every year at the beginning of the term: how a man bet four hundred zuzim that he could make Hillel

angry, and came to his door on the eve of the Sabbath while he was washing, shouting, *Where is Hillel? Where is Hillel?* and asked him why the Babylonians had round heads, and an hour later why the people of Tadmor had weak eyes, and an hour after that why the Africans had broad feet; and how every time Hillel wrapped his mantle round him and came out and said, *Ask on, my son,* and answered him, until the man had lost all his money. He told it to the end, in his slow Dutch, standing in the street with the fish scale on his collar, and the boys who had been following them stood a little way off and listened, because nobody in New Amsterdam had told them a story that winter.

> *"Be warned for the future," said Hillel; "better it is that thou shouldst lose four hundred zouzim, and four hundred more after them, than it should be said of Hillel he lost his temper!"*
>
> *— Shabbath 31a*

The two Company men had set their casks down. They had been standing behind the boys, and now one of them, a tall man with grey in his hair, came a step closer.

The old man looked at him and said something to him in Portuguese, and the man answered in Portuguese.

V. The Stuivers

New Amsterdam · spring 1655

His name was Domingo. He had been born in Angola and baptized at Luanda by a Portuguese priest, and sold to the Dutch, and carried to Recife, and from Recife to this island, where the Company owned him and rented him out by the day. He had not heard his own language spoken to him as to a man in eleven years. He told Valverde that, standing by the horse mill, and Valverde told him who had been paying the boys, and Domingo said he knew.

The next morning the old man went out walking at the same hour, up the Heerestraat to the land gate and back. Two boys followed him, out of

habit, and called him an ass, and then, because nobody took it up, stopped. A sailor said something. A woman in a doorway told the sailor to hold his tongue.

By the end of March the old man walked alone. By April the boys walked with him, because he would tell them a story if they did, about Hillel, or about the elephant, or about Recife; and one of them, a cooper's boy named Jochem, could tell the whole of the Hillel story by Pentecost without a mistake, and did, to anyone who would stand for it. The other Company man, Francisco, began to come to the back room on the Brugh Straat on Friday evenings and stand in the door, and after a while to sit, and Valverde gave him bread with the rest. People said afterward, in Dutch and in Portuguese, that every one of them who had been paid to shout at him that winter had come round, every one, and that nobody in the town could say quite how it had been done, since he had never once answered any of them back.

In June the Company's letter came from Amsterdam, written at the end of April. The directors could not, they said, consent to send the Jews away, in view of the large losses the nation had suffered in Brazil and the capital it had invested in the Company's shares. They might live and trade in New Netherland, provided their poor did not become a burden to the deacons. It was read in the council.

Domingo came to the tap-house by the warehouse the morning after the letter was read on the Strand, with the boys who swept and three of the sailors behind him, and they laid the stuivers Margriet Claes had paid them on her counter in a row, every one, and some of them worn smooth, and went out. She stood behind the counter and looked at the row of coins for a long time. Then she swept them into her apron, because they were money.

Valverde lived four more years. When he died they buried him in the little burying ground outside the wall that the Jews had at last been granted, the first ground the Jews of New Amsterdam ever owned. The boys who had once followed him up the Heerestraat shouting carried him there, Jochem the cooper's son at the front, and Domingo walked behind.

Background

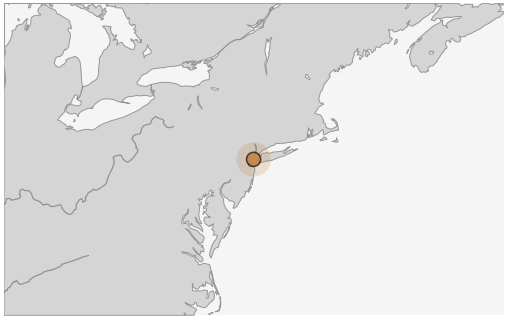
The verses

> *Silently shall I endure abuse as the elephant in battle endures the arrow sent from the bow: for the world is ill-natured.*
>
> Dhammapada 320, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *They lead a tamed elephant to battle, the king mounts a tamed elephant; the tamed is the best among men, he who silently endures abuse.*
>
> Dhammapada 321, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Mules are good, if tamed, and noble Sindhu horses, and elephants with large tusks; but he who tames himself is better still.*
>
> Dhammapada 322, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Māgandiyā, whose father once offered her to the Buddha and heard her body called a thing of filth, becomes a queen and never forgives him. She bribes townspeople and slaves to follow him through the streets with the ten terms of abuse: thief, fool, ox, ass, beast of hell, with no hope of heaven. Ānanda begs him to go to another city. And if they abuse us there? Then another. The Buddha answers that trouble should be settled where it arises, and compares himself to an elephant in battle that bears the arrows from all four quarters. By the end of his teaching the people who had been paid to revile him have entered the stream. Read the full commentary story; the grudge begins in commentary 2.1.



New Amsterdam (Manhattan), New Netherland

New Amsterdam, 1654–55

In early September 1654 twenty-three Jews from Dutch Brazil, four men, six women and thirteen children by one count, landed at New Amsterdam on the bark *Sainte Catherine*, after the Portuguese retook Recife. The master, Jacques de la Motthe, sued

them for their passage, and the court held their goods against the debt. Director-General Peter Stuyvesant wrote to the West India Company asking to expel them, citing their "customary usury and deceitful trading with the Christians." On April 26, 1655 the directors refused, pointing to the Jews' losses in Brazil and their capital in the Company, and let them stay so long as their poor did not burden the deacons. They could not worship in public or buy a house; in February 1656 they were granted a burial ground. Their congregation, Shearith Israel, is the oldest in the United States.

Most of the Company's enslaved workers in New Amsterdam came from West Central Africa and were Catholic and Portuguese-speaking, with names like Anthony, Manuel or Gracia "van Angola"; in 1644 eleven of the longest-held men were given half-freedom and land north of the town. Hansken, the elephant Rembrandt drew in Amsterdam in 1637, toured the fairs of Europe for eighteen years, waving a flag, firing a pistol and picking coins out of pockets, and died in Florence in November 1655. The story of Hillel and the man who bet four hundred zuzim he could make him angry is told in the Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 31a; the version quoted is from *Hebraic Literature*, edited by Maurice H. Harris and first published in 1901. Valverde, Margriet Claes, Domingo and the rest are invented.

After the story of the Buddha reviled in Kosambī from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 320–322). The original. The Talmud passage (Shabbath 31a) is from *Hebraic Literature: Translations from the Talmud, Midrashim and Kabbala* (ed. Maurice H. Harris, 1901). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.2

Green Broke

> *What then is your own? The use of appearances.*
> *— Epictetus, Encheiridion 6*

The way I heard it, on the minimum yard.

I. Mister

Sixmile Conservation Camp, near Carson City, Nevada · August 2014

Odell Pruitt called everybody Mister. He had been calling everybody Mister since 1979, when he came into the Nevada State Prison at thirty-seven with a life sentence for killing a man in the parking lot of a Reno card room, and it had gotten him into fights the first ten years, because the men thought he was mocking them, and the officers thought he was mocking them, and some of the time he was. After that it stopped being mockery. It was just what he said. Mister Ochoa. Mister Bledsoe. Mister Officer Grant. By 2014 he was seventy-two years old, with a white beard trimmed close and reading glasses on a cord, and he had been moved down through the custody levels one at a time over thirty-five years until he arrived at Sixmile, a minimum camp in the sagebrush south of Carson City, where there was a chain-link fence you could have climbed in a minute and nobody did.

On Tuesday nights after chow he held a reading group in the education trailer. It was not on any list of programs and it did not earn anybody any good time. There were eight or nine men in it, sometimes twelve, sometimes four. They read one book, the same book, over and over, a library copy of Epictetus with the spine held together by packing tape and a Carson City Library stamp from 1971, which Pruitt had carried with him through four institutions and was the only thing he owned that he would

have fought for. Epictetus had been a slave. He walked lame all his life, and some said it was because his master had broken his leg. He had taught that a man could be chained at the ankle and be free, and the men in the Tuesday group did not think this was a nice idea. They thought it was either a lie or the only true thing anybody had ever said to them, and they came back on Tuesdays to find out which.

Royce Etcheverry had been coming since May.

He was sixty-one, the oldest after Pruitt. He had a buckaroo's walk, a little bowlegged and very straight, and hands like old harness, and a burn scar down the left side of his neck that went under his collar. His grandfather had come from Navarre in 1913 to herd sheep for a Basque outfit out of Winnemucca and had stayed. Royce had grown up on the big ranches of Humboldt County and had been, for thirty years, the best colt starter in northern Nevada. People said so who did not like him. He could get on a four-year-old that had never been touched and have it carrying a rider through a gate in a week, and the ranches paid him for it, and he was proud of it the way some men are proud of a son.

In November of 2010 he had left the bar in Winnemucca at closing with a gooseneck trailer behind his pickup and three of a rancher's colts in the trailer, and on Interstate 80 east of Lovelock, in a crosswind, the trailer had come around on him. The truck rolled. A woman named Diane Harbin, forty-four, a dental hygienist from Fernley, driving home from her sister's in a Subaru, died in it. So did two of the colts. Royce lived. He was doing eight to twenty.

He did not talk in the Tuesday group. He sat at the end of the table with his arms crossed and listened, and when the book went around and it was his turn to read a paragraph out loud he read it slowly and correctly and passed it on. Once, in July, Pruitt asked him what he thought a thing meant, a passage about what is in our power and what is not, and Royce said, *I'd say it means what it says,* and Pruitt said, *Mister Etcheverry, I believe that's right,* and did not ask him again.

II. The Round Pen

The horse pens · September

THE EDUCATION TRAILER STOOD AT THE SOUTH END OF THE camp, and to get back to the units from it you walked along the fence of the horse program.

The program had been running in Nevada since before Royce came in. The Bureau of Land Management gathered wild horses off the ranges every year, more than anybody wanted to adopt, and some of them came in trailers to the prisons, where the inmates gentled them and started them under saddle for about four months, and then the horses went through a public adoption a few times a year, a competitive bid, with an auctioneer, and families from Reno and Gardnerville and California bid on them and took them home. Each horse had a freeze mark on the left side of its neck, white hair in a row of angled symbols that told the year it was born and its number. Each one came off a herd management area with a name, Fish Creek, Little Owyhee, Triple B, the names of dry country. The men in the program got paid a little, worked outside all day, and came back to the unit smelling of horse, and there was a waiting list to get in.

Royce was not on the list. He had put in for it when he came to Sixmile and been told no, on account of the colts in the trailer. He worked on the hay crew instead, moving the wheel lines on the camp's alfalfa, and he walked past the round pen twice a day and did not look at it, and walked past it on Tuesday nights and looked.

That September there was a gray gelding in the round pen that nobody could saddle. He was a four-year-old off the Fish Creek range, fourteen hands and some, dark dapples on his rump going to white, with a white blaze, and he would take the halter now, and lead, and stand to be brushed, but when the saddle pad came near his back he exploded. The kid who had him was named Danny Portillo. He was twenty-four, from East Las Vegas, the son of Salvadorans who had come up through Mexico in 1989 and cleaned rooms at the Stardust until the day they blew it up. He was doing three years on a burglary. He had never touched a horse in

his life before May, and the horse program was the best thing that had ever happened to him, and he would have told you so, and he was afraid of the gray in a way he had not been afraid of anything on the street. He called the horse Humo. Smoke. The adoption was the second Saturday of October, and the catalog was due to the BLM in a week, with a photograph of every horse under saddle and a paragraph about it written by its trainer, and Humo would not take a saddle.

Royce and five of the Tuesday men came along the fence after group that night, in the last light, with the mountains going purple over Carson City. Danny was in the round pen alone, past the time he should have been, with the pad in his hands and Humo at the far side of the pen with his head up and the whites of his eyes showing. Danny walked toward him with the pad held out low, the way they had taught him, slow, and stopped, and waited, and came on, and Humo went straight up and spun and hit the panels so hard the whole pen rang.

The men stopped at the fence. Bledsoe, who had been in the group longest after Royce, said, *That boy is going to get killed.*

Royce had his hands on the chain-link. He watched the gray come down off the panel and trot the rail, blowing, and he watched Danny stand in the middle with the pad, and his face did something none of them had seen it do at the Tuesday table. It woke up.

He's going about it backwards, Royce said. *That horse has been bluffing him for a month and he knows it. What you do with a horse like that, you take a soft cotton rope and tie up that off hind foot to his neck, so he's standing on three legs and can't go anywhere, and then you sack him out. Slap that pad on him, on his back, his belly, his legs, everywhere, and keep at it. He'll fight it. Let him fight it. He'll go down, maybe. Let him lie there and keep on. Twenty minutes, half an hour, and he'll quit. You'll see it in his eye when he quits. And then you can set a saddle on him and he'll stand there like a sawhorse.*

He said it the way a man says something he has said a thousand times to young cowboys in a corral, easily, with a kind of pleasure, and when he had said it he looked surprised at himself and took his hands off the fence.

Danny Portillo was forty feet away, in the round pen, with his back to them. He did not turn around. But he had heard every word.

III. Green Broke

The round pen · the next evening

THE PROGRAM SUPERVISOR WAS A CIVILIAN FROM DAYTON named Hal Nygaard, who had trained horses all his life and believed in going slow. He went home at four. Danny waited until he was gone, and the officer at the barn was busy with a count sheet, and the other trainers had put their horses up. Then he went into the tack room and got a soft cotton rope.

He had trouble getting the loop around the hind pastern. Humo kicked him once in the thigh, hard, and he limped for a week afterward. But he got it, and ran the rope up through a loop around the gray's neck and pulled the foot up under the belly and tied it off, the way he had heard it, and then Humo was standing on three legs in the middle of the pen with his nostrils open and his whole body shaking.

Danny picked up the saddle pad.

The two men who saw it from the hay barn told it afterward, and so did Danny, much later. Humo fought. He hopped on three legs and threw himself sideways and went down in the dirt of the pen and lay there groaning and thrashing his head, and got up, and Danny kept on with the pad, slapping it on his back, his neck, under his belly, down his legs, over and over, the way he had heard it, while the dust came up gold in the low sun. The horse went down again. He lay on his side a long time. Danny slapped the pad on his ribs where they heaved. He said afterward that he talked to the horse the whole time, said *ya, ya, ya, ya está, ya está,* it's done, it's done, and that he was crying, and that he did not stop.

Then the horse got up and stood. He stood on three legs with his head down and the pad on his back and did not move. Danny took the pad off and put it on and took it off. Humo did not move. Danny untied the foot. Humo set it down and did not move. Danny walked to the rail and got the

saddle and swung it up onto the gray's back and pulled the cinch, and the horse stood there like a sawhorse, the way Royce had said.

Danny rode him the next morning in front of Hal Nygaard, walk and trot, both directions around the pen. Nygaard was amazed and said so. He said he had been about to send that horse back to the BLM short-term corral as unadoptable and he did not know what Danny had done but whatever it was, keep doing it. They took the catalog photograph that afternoon: Danny in the saddle in his prison blues and a ball cap, Humo standing square with his head low.

That night in the unit Danny wrote his paragraph for the catalog, three tries, on lined paper, and turned it in.

Humo is a quiet gelding who stands well to saddle and gives no trouble. At first he was nervous but he is a fast learner. He will make somebody a good horse.

Royce saw the horse two days later, walking back from the alfalfa. Danny was leading him around the pen on a loose rope and the gray followed with his head at Danny's shoulder, low, and when Danny stopped he stopped. Royce stood at the fence a long time. He knew that walk. He knew the eye. He had made it in a hundred horses and been paid for it, the eye that has stopped expecting anything, and he had always called it quitting, and he had always thought it was the beginning of a good horse.

He did not say anything. He went back to the unit and lay on his bunk until count.

IV. Is It True

The education trailer · Tuesday

It was Bledsoe who told Pruitt. He was not a talker either; he told it because it had been sitting on him all week. He told it before group, when it was just the two of them setting out the chairs, the whole thing, the fence and the rope and what the hay crew saw from the barn and the paragraph in the catalog, which one of the clerks had shown around. Pruitt listened with his reading glasses in his hand. Then he put them on and opened the book and waited for the others.

When they were all there, nine of them, and Royce at the end of the table with his arms crossed, Pruitt did not open the book. He looked down the table.

Mister Etcheverry.

Royce looked at him.

On Tuesday last, at the round pen, did you tell those men how to tie up that gray horse's foot and sack him out until he quit?

Nobody moved. Somebody's chair creaked and stopped.

Yes, Royce said. *I did. It's true.*

Pruitt nodded slowly, as if a man had told him the time.

Mister Etcheverry, he said, *what have you got to do with horses?*

He did not raise his voice. He never had to, in thirty-five years. He said it quietly and it went down the table like cold water.

You are a man in blue in a camp in the desert with eight to twenty and a woman named Diane Harbin dead on the interstate. You came in here in May and sat at that end of this table and read this book like a man reading the instructions on a can. You never said a word in four months. And the first time anything in this place wakes you up, the first time, it's that boy out there with a horse he can't handle. And what you have to give him is how to tie it up so it can't move and beat on it till it gives up. That's what you've got. That's the thing you were best at in the world.

He opened the book now. He did not need to look for the place.

You think that horse is going to carry you somewhere? Out of here? Any horse? A man can ride all the horses in Nevada, Mister, he can start every colt from here to Elko and do it in a week, and never once go anywhere he hasn't already been. He turned the book around on the table so Royce could see the page. *Read that.*

Royce uncrossed his arms and pulled the book to him and read it out loud, slowly and correctly, the way he always did.

> *Be not elated at any advantage (excellence) which belongs to another. If a horse when he is elated should say, I am beautiful, one might endure it. But when you are elated, and say, I have a beautiful horse, you must know that you are elated at having a good horse. What then is your own? The use of appearances.*
>
> *— Epictetus, Encheiridion 6*

What's your own, Mister Etcheverry? said Pruitt.

Royce sat with his hand flat on the page.

Not the horse, Pruitt said. *Not that gray and not those two colts in the trailer either, God rest them, and not your hands, and not your name in Humboldt County. There is only one animal in this trailer you've got any business breaking, and you haven't laid a rope on him in sixty-one years.* He took the book back and turned some pages, near the end, to the long chapter about freedom that the group had read in June, and read it himself this time, to all of them.

> *Your body then is another's, subject to every man who is stronger than yourself. It is. But your estate is it in your power to have it when you please, and as long as you please, and such as you please? No. And your slaves? No. And your clothes? No. And your house? No. And your horses? Not one of these things.*
>
> *— Epictetus, Discourses 4.1*

Tame that one, said Pruitt. *And then you can go someplace.*

Then he said, *Mister Bledsoe, page forty, if you would,* and they went on with the group, and nobody looked at Royce for the rest of the hour, which was the kindest thing they knew how to do.

V. The Adoption

The horse pens · the second Saturday of October

The adoption came on a cold bright Saturday with the first snow on the Carson Range. The public came in through a side gate

AT THE SOUTH END OF THE CAMP, A HUNDRED AND FIFTY people in down vests and good boots, with horse trailers lined up along the road outside, and walked along the pens with their catalogs reading the paragraphs. Nobody in blue denim. No cell phones. No photographs. The trainers rode their horses around the arena one at a time while the auctioneer talked them up, and the bidding started at a hundred and fifty dollars.

The hay crew was not allowed down there. Royce watched from the far edge of the alfalfa, beside the wheel line, a quarter mile off, where he could see the arena small and bright with the people around it like a ring of birds.

When Danny rode Humo into the arena the gray went around once at a walk and once at a trot, head low, ears neither forward nor back, and stopped when Danny stopped him, and stood. A family from Minden bought him for four hundred and twenty-five dollars, a man and his wife and a girl of about eleven in a pink parka who had been standing at Humo's pen all morning reading the paragraph out loud to her parents. Danny led the horse out to their trailer himself, because the trainers were allowed to do that. He told Royce about it months later in the chow line, the only time they ever spoke of it. He said the girl asked him if Humo was a nice horse. He said he told her Humo was a good horse, which was true, and that he would make somebody a good horse, which was true, and that she should go slow with him, very slow, slower than she thought, and if he ever got scared, she should just stand there with him and wait until they both quit being scared.

I don't know if he'll ever come back, Danny said. *In his eye. You know?*

Royce said he knew.

VI. Wheel Lines

The camp alfalfa · that fall and winter

SOME OF THE MEN IN THE ROOM THAT NIGHT SAID AFTERWARD that something happened to them, sitting there, that had not happened in any program or chapel or court. Bledsoe said it was like hearing some-

BODY SAY YOUR NAME IN A PLACE WHERE YOU DIDN'T KNOW anybody knew it. A young man named Teo Maldonado, who had come to the group twice before and not liked it, came every Tuesday after that until he was paroled in 2016, and wrote Pruitt letters from Reno for years. They said things changed for them from that night. They did not say how.

Royce did not come to group the next Tuesday. He came the one after, and sat in the same place, and when the book came to him he read his paragraph, and then he said, without being asked, *I don't know how to do it.* And Pruitt said, *No, Mister. Nobody does. You do it anyway.*

He did not go along the fence by the round pen anymore. He went back the long way after group, around by the kitchen, and he moved the wheel lines in the alfalfa in the mornings, twelve hundred feet of aluminum pipe on wheels taller than a man, that you uncoupled and rolled forward by a crank, one set at a time, to put the water on the next strip of the field. It was work you could not hurry. If you hurried the line bowed and the couplings bent and you spent the afternoon fixing them. He learned to stand at the mover with his hands on the crank and wait until his breathing came down before he started it, and then the whole quarter mile of wheels rolled forward together, slowly, straight, and stopped where he stopped it, and the sprinklers came on and the water went out over the new strip in long arcs and soaked into the ground and ran a little way down the furrows in the low places, and the old men on the hay crew said that was where the water wanted to go.

At night he lay on his bunk and said her name. Diane Harbin. He had said it at his sentencing, reading from a paper, and not since. He said it now every night, once, before count, not as a prayer, because he did not know any, but the way you set a foot down on ground you are not sure of. Some nights he said the names of the colts too. He had not known them. He gave them names.

He found that the thing in him that had wakened at the round pen, the thing that had reached for the rope, woke up all the time, a dozen times a day, at the chow line and the phone and the officer who said his name wrong, and that it had always been waking up, every day of his life, and

he had always called it being good at something. Now when he felt it he did what he did at the wheel line. He stood with his hands where they were and waited until his breath came down. It did not always work. Once in December he put a man against the wall of the laundry for cutting in line and was written up and lost thirty days' good time, and he went to group that Tuesday and said so, at the table, before anybody else could, and Pruitt said, *Mister Etcheverry, that is the first true thing I have heard all week,* and gave him the book to read from.

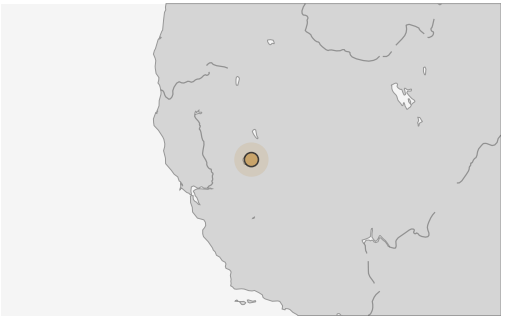
One morning in January he was out on the wheel line at six, in the dark, before the rest of the hay crew. There was frost on the alfalfa and the pipe was so cold it burned his hands through his gloves. He set them on the crank of the mover and stood there and waited, and watched his breath go out white in front of him and come back in, out and in, until it had slowed down to nothing much, and the mountains were coming up grey over Carson City, and somewhere back at the pens a horse he had never seen nickered once for its feed. Then he turned the crank, and the whole long line of wheels began to roll forward together across the field, slowly, all of them at once, straight, and stopped where he stopped it.

Background

The verse

> *For with these animals does no man reach the untrodden country (Nirvana), where a tamed man goes on a tamed animal, viz. on his own well-tamed self.*
>
> Dhammapada 323, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk who had been an elephant trainer before he was ordained stands with other monks on the bank of the Aciravatī river, watching a trainer fail to teach an elephant a trick. He remarks that if the man pricked the elephant in a certain place it would learn quickly. The trainer overhears, does it, and the elephant submits. The other monks report it to the Buddha, who calls the monk in, asks whether it is true, and on hearing yes rebukes him: what has he to do with elephants or any tamed animal? No such vehicle carries a man to the place he has never been; only his own well-tamed self can. Many who heard the teaching were set on the path. Read the full commentary story, or about Epictetus, the freed slave whose sayings stand in for the verse here.



Carson City, Nevada

Nevada, 2014

Wild horses on Nevada's public ranges were hunted from airplanes and trucks for pet-food plants until a Reno woman, Velma Johnston, known as Wild Horse Annie, followed a bleeding truckload to a slaughterhouse in 1950 and spent the rest of her life campaigning. A 1959 law banned hunting them with motor vehicles and aircraft, and the Wild and Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act of 1971 made them "living symbols of the historic and pioneer spirit of the West" under federal protection. The Bureau of Land Management gathers horses off the ranges and offers them for adoption, each freeze-marked on the left side of the neck with its birth year and number; since about 2001 removals have outrun adoptions.

Sixmile Conservation Camp is fictional; its program is modeled on the real one at the Northern Nevada Correctional Center in Carson City, which began in October 2000 and since 2007 has trained only BLM wild horses and burros. Inmates, often with little or no experience of horses, give each animal about 120 days of training; the horses go out “green broke” through public competitive-bid adoptions several times a year, with bids starting at $150 and a catalog paragraph written by each trainer. Visitors may not wear blue denim. Royce's people are the Basques of northern Nevada, who came from the Spanish and French Pyrenees to herd sheep and settled around Winnemucca, Elko and Battle Mountain, which still have some of the highest shares of Basque ancestry in the country. The camp's hay is watered by wheel lines, rolling sprinkler pipe moved forward one set at a time.

After the story of the monk who had been an elephant trainer, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 323). The original. Epictetus in the translation of George Long. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.3

The Cane

Fathers divide house and substance to their children.
— Proverbs 19:14 (Septuagint)

Hēk smi"it, on North Broadway.

I. Four Envelopes

Knoxville, Tennessee · 2021

Elias Musleh opened his first store on North Broadway in 1974, in a cinder-block building that had been a filling station, with a cooler of milk and a cooler of beer and a rack of bread and a hot plate behind the counter where his wife Samira made the pies she sold by the slice to the men from the cabinet shop next door. He was twenty-nine. He had been in Knoxville eight years. By 1990 he had four stores, one on Broadway and one on Chapman Highway and one on Clinton Highway and one out Magnolia Avenue past the old Sears, gas and groceries and cold beer and lottery tickets and a hot case with fried chicken and spinach pies, and a sign on every one in red letters that said MUSLEH MARKET, and four sons, Hanna and Issa and Fadi and Sami, who had done their homework on milk crates behind four different counters and grown up and married and gone into the stores themselves.

He gave each of them a store on the day of his wedding. It was the way his own father had done in Ramallah with the olive terraces, one terrace to each son when he married, the way everybody did. He kept the house on the ridge in West Knoxville, and the money in the bank, and Samira.

Samira died in January of 2021, at the hospital, of the sickness, on a telephone. The nurse held the telephone to her ear in the room and Elias talked to her from the parking lot, sitting in his Buick, until the nurse

came back on and said that she was gone. They buried her with twelve people at the grave in masks, and the priest from the Greek church in a mask, and the Ramallah families who would have come by the hundred watching on their phones.

For a while after that, his sons were very good to him.

They took turns coming by. The wives sent stuffed grape leaves and lentils and rice. They rubbed his hands when his knuckles hurt. Sami, the youngest, knelt on the rug and took his father's shoes off and rubbed his feet with Samira's olive oil out of the last tin she had brought from Ramallah, and Elias let him, and thought it was love, and some of it was.

The other part of it had a name, and the name was Um Jiries, a widow in Ramallah who had been at school with Samira, and who had written Elias a message of condolence on the telephone that spring, and then another message, and then had begun to call him on Sunday nights, after nine, because of the time.

The sons did not say her name. They talked about the house on the ridge, the stairs, the taxes, the yard. They did not say, if he marries a woman from back home and brings her here, it all goes to her, and her children by the first husband, and the house and the bank account go with them to Ramallah. They did not need to say it. They said it to each other in the stores after closing, and their wives said it to each other on the telephone, and Elias heard them say it without their saying it, and pretended he had not.

One Sunday at the end of the summer they found him asleep in his chair at two in the afternoon with the television on, and when he woke up all four of them were in the room, and Fadi was rubbing his hands.

Yaba, said Hanna. *Why should you live alone? Come live with us. We'll take care of you as long as you live. Sell the house. Give us the rest now, while you can see us enjoy it. What do you need it for? You have us.*

At the end of September he signed the papers at a lawyer's office on Kingston Pike, a Ramallah boy whose grandfather Elias had known. The house sold in a week. The lawyer gave him four envelopes, and he wrote a name on each, in Arabic and then in English, oldest to youngest. He kept for himself two pairs of trousers and four shirts and his good suit and his

overcoat, his reading glasses, his wife's last tin of oil, which was nearly empty, and the old oud he had brought from Ramallah in 1966 in a case held shut with a belt and had not played in thirty years.

II. The Doors

Farragut, Powell, Halls · fall and winter, 2021

He went to Hanna's first, because Hanna was the oldest. Hanna had a house in Farragut with a three-car garage and a pool with a cover on it for the winter, and his wife Rula gave Elias the guest room downstairs and put the oud in the closet.

It was good for three weeks. Then it was the dishes, and his television too loud, and his cigarettes on the back deck. On a Saturday in November he came back from the Greek church, where he had stood through the liturgy as long as his knees would let him and then sat, and Rula was standing in the open door of the garage with her arms folded, and she said it before he was out of the car.

Did you give Hanna a thousand dollars more than the others? A hundred? You gave every one of them the same. I saw the papers. So why is it always this house? Don't you know the way to Issa's? To Fadi's? You don't remember how to drive to Powell?

Elias stood by the car. He said something to her in Arabic that his mother had said to people, a thing about God and her house, that he had never in his life said to a woman, and he got back in the car and drove to Powell.

He was at Issa's until the middle of December. Then Dana said it, in a different way, with the children listening on the stairs. He was at Fadi's in Halls for two weeks, in a room with an exercise bicycle in it. He was at Sami's for nine days. Sami's wife was an American girl from Maryville named Lisa whom Elias had liked very much at the wedding, and she did not say anything at all. She only began to set the table for four instead of five, and went on doing it.

On the tenth day he put his clothes in a garbage bag and took the oud in its case and drove away from Sami's and did not go anywhere. There

was nowhere to go. There were four houses, and he had been put out of all of them, and the money that would have bought a fifth was in the four envelopes. He slept that night in the Buick in the parking lot of a Kroger. In January the Buick went back to Hanna, because it was in Hanna's name now, like everything else, and Hanna sent a cousin to get it, and did not come himself.

• • •

The mission was on Broadway, two blocks from the store.

He had looked at it out of the window of the first store for forty years, the men on the sidewalk in the morning waiting for the door with their bags. He had sold them cigarettes one at a time, and coffee, and honey buns. Now he waited on the sidewalk in the morning with his garbage bag and his oud, and went in, and they gave him a cot and a locker and a number. Some of the men knew him. They called him Pops. They did not ask him what had happened. Nobody at the mission asked that.

He did not go past the store. He walked the long way around, by Central, so that Hanna would not see him through the window, and he walked downtown in the mornings when they put the men out of the mission, with the others, and spent the days where they spent them, in the bus station and in the library. He ate what the churches brought. He lost weight. He coughed. He let his beard come in white. He bought a cane for nine dollars at the Dollar General on Broadway, an aluminum one with a rubber foot, because his knee had gone, and because there was a dog on the corner of Fifth Avenue that did not like him, and with the cane he could keep it off.

At the end of January, on a cold afternoon, he woke on a bench in the library on Church Avenue, on the second floor, where he had sat down to read a newspaper and fallen asleep sitting up, and he did not know for a moment where he was. Then he did. He looked at his hands. They were an old man's hands, dirty in the creases, the nails long. He looked at his trousers. He thought: I have four sons. I have four sons, and there is not one door in this city I can knock on.

He had heard the men talk about the woman at the desk downstairs.

They said she never frowned. They said she called you by your name and said good morning to you the same way she said it to the lawyers who came in to use the computers, and that she would look anything up for you, a phone number in Detroit, a man you were in the Army with, the rules about your disability check. They said she was the only person in Knoxville who looked at you when she talked to you.

He thought: maybe she will look at me.

He combed his beard with his fingers and put on his overcoat and took the cane and went downstairs.

III. The Desk

Lawson McGhee Library, Church Avenue · January 2022

Her name was Avis Nance. She was sixty-six years old, and she had been a reference librarian on Church Avenue for thirty-eight years, and she had grown up in Burlington, on the east side, and when she was a little girl the library on Church Avenue had not been for her. There had been the other library then, the colored library, and then there had not been, and she had come downtown on the bus at nine years old with her library card in her hand to the big library, and the woman at the desk had looked at her for a long time, and given her the book. She had not been to church since her mother died. She said she had read too much. She had a short grey natural and reading glasses on a beaded chain and a face that, as the men said, did not frown. It was not that it smiled. It was that it was open, like a door that was not going to close on you.

She looked up at him from the desk.

Mr. Musleh, she said.

He had not expected that. He stood there with the cane.

You had the store on Broadway. I used to buy my milk at your store when I lived on Fourth and Gill. Twenty years. Your wife made the spinach pies. She took her glasses off and let them hang on the chain. *Sit down. Sit down, Mr. Musleh. What happened to you? How come you're dressed like that?*

He sat down in the chair at the end of the desk, where people sat to ask her for things. It had been a long time since anybody had told him to

sit down. He told her. He told it badly, in pieces, with his English coming and going the way it did now when he was tired. The tin of oil. The four envelopes. Rula in the garage door. The table set for four. The Buick, and the cousin who came to get it. He did not cry, telling it. He had not cried since Samira, on the telephone, in the parking lot.

Avis Nance listened to all of it and did not say anything until he was done. Then she said:

You're Orthodox. The Greek church.

Yes.

She got up and went into the stacks behind the desk, and came back with a heavy book with a green cover, and sat down and turned the pages a long time with her glasses back on, and wrote on the little paper slips the library kept for call numbers, with a short pencil, in a librarian's hand, very clear. Three slips. She put them in front of him on the desk in a row.

This is the Bible your church uses. The old Greek one, put into English. She tapped the slips. *Learn these. By heart. And when your people are all together in one place, all of them, and your boys are there with them, you stand up and say them out loud.*

He looked at the slips. He looked at her.

That's all?

That's all.

He put them in the pocket of his overcoat and went back to the mission, and that night on his cot, and the next day on the bench on the second floor, and in the bus station, and walking the long way around by Central, he said them over and over under his breath in English and then put them into Arabic in his head, until he could say them both ways without the paper, the way he had learned the psalms as a boy in the Church of the Transfiguration, standing beside his mother.

IV. The Wedding

A hotel ballroom on the river · February 19, 2022

ALL THAT WINTER, EVERYBODY HAD BEEN GETTING MARRIED. The weddings that had been put off in 2020 and put off again in 2021 were all happening at once, in the winter of 2022, as if the whole community had been holding its breath. The one in February, a few weeks before Lent, when the church would stop marrying anybody until Easter, was a granddaughter of his cousin Khalil, marrying a Ramallah boy from Detroit, and it was at the big hotel by the river downtown, and everybody was there. Everybody. The Ramallah families of Knoxville and the ones from Detroit and Chicago and Jacksonville, three hundred and fifty people at round tables, the old men nearest the dance floor, the women in their gold.

His sons sat at a table near the front, all four of them, with their wives, in good suits, under a centerpiece of white roses. Rula had on the gold bracelets Samira had left her. Hanna had his reading glasses pushed up on his head, the way Elias wore his.

Elias came in at ten o'clock. The doorman did not want to let him in, and then a cousin's boy recognized him and went white and let him in. He came in his overcoat and the trousers he had been wearing for a week, with his white beard and the aluminum cane, and the band was between songs. They had just carried the groom around the floor on their shoulders in the zaffe, the young men, with the drums going and everybody clapping, and set him down, and the floor was still full of people catching their breath. Elias walked through them. Some of them knew him and some did not. The ones who knew him stopped talking. He went up the two steps to where the band was and took the microphone from the singer, who let him have it because he was old, and turned around, and raised his hand.

I want to say something. Please. Listen to me.

It got quiet from the front of the room to the back, the way a room does. Somebody said, *Go ahead, ammi. We're listening.*

He said it in Arabic first, for the old ones, the way he had made it in his head on the cot. Then he said it again in English for the young ones, who had grown up here and did not have enough Arabic for the Bible, slowly, out of the slips in his overcoat pocket that he did not need to take out.

> *Fathers divide house and substance to their children.*
>
> *Cast me not off at the time of old age; forsake me not when my strength fails.*
>
> *He that dishonours his father, and drives away his mother, shall be disgraced and shall be exposed to reproach.*
>
> *— Proverbs 19:14; Psalm 70:9; Proverbs 19:26 (Septuagint)*

Then he lifted the cane, so the whole room could see it.

I have four sons, he said, in Arabic and then in English. *Their names are Hanna, Issa, Fadi, and Sami. Every one of them is sitting at that table. I gave them everything I had. I bought this for nine dollars at the Dollar General. It is a better son to me than four sons. It holds me up. It keeps the dogs off me on Broadway at night.*

He put the microphone back in the stand and stood there leaning on the cane.

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Nobody spoke for a long time. Then Abu Nabil stood up from the old men's table, slowly, with a hand on his chair, because he was ninety-one. He had come from Ramallah in 1952. He had been at every wedding and every funeral of the Ramallah families of Knoxville for seventy years, and he had buried Samira on a telephone too, and nobody alive in that room had ever heard him raise his voice.

He did not raise it now.

In the old days in the balad, said Abu Nabil, *a man who ate his father's bread and put his father in the street, they would have finished him. Nobody would sell to him. Nobody would buy from him. Nobody would give him a daughter for his son or take his daughter for theirs. When he died nobody would*

carry him. He was dead already. They only had to wait. He looked at the table under the white roses. *This is not the old days. It is Tennessee. But I am telling you, Hanna, and you, Issa, and Fadi, and Sami. If I hear one more night that your father sleeps at the mission on Broadway, it will be the old days. For you, it will be the old days. Every family in this room will see to it.*

At the other tables the old men nodded, one after another, and some of the women, and Khalil, whose granddaughter's wedding it was, said it out loud: *Every family.*

Hanna got up first. He came across the dance floor in his good suit with his face gone grey and went down on his knees on the parquet in front of his father, in front of three hundred and fifty people, and put his forehead on his father's shoes. Then Issa, and Fadi, and Sami. *Yaba. Yaba, forgive us. Don't let them. Yaba.*

Elias looked down at the four heads. Hanna's was going thin on top. He had not noticed. He had not looked down at the top of his son's head since Hanna was a boy.

Leave them, he said to Abu Nabil, and to the room. *Leave them alone. They'll take care of me. They're good boys.*

Then let them take care of you, said Abu Nabil, and sat down.

The four of them got up off the floor. Hanna went and got a chair from the nearest table, one of the hotel's banquet chairs with the white cover tied on with a sash, and they sat their father in it, and each of them took a leg of it, and they lifted him, the way the young men had lifted the groom an hour before, and carried him across the dance floor and out of the ballroom and down the hall past the elevators and out to Hanna's car under the hotel portico. The band did not play. Nobody clapped. The wedding went on behind them, after a while, because weddings do.

V. The Card

Farragut · March and April 2022

Hanna bathed him himself that night, in the big bathroom upstairs, on his knees by the tub, and washed his hair with the good shampoo, and trimmed his nails with the clippers from Rula's drawer, the

WAY YOU DO IT FOR A CHILD, AND SHAVED HIM IN THE MORNing. Then he called his brothers and their wives and Rula into the kitchen and said, in Arabic and then in English so there could be no mistake, that their father would live a week in each of their houses, around and around, as long as he lived, with the best room and the first plate.

Nobody said anything. Rula went upstairs and came down with clean sheets for the downstairs room, and made the bed, and took the oud out of the closet in its case and leaned it in the corner by the window where he could see it.

He slept. He ate. He ate roast chicken with rice and pine nuts and Rula's lentil soup, and the color came back into him in two weeks and the cough went away and his knee was better. He looked at himself in the mirror in the downstairs bathroom with his beard trimmed short and white, and thought: I owe this to the woman at the desk.

He had no money to buy her anything. Everything had been in the envelopes. So he went into the garage, where Hanna had put the boxes from the house on the ridge, and found the one with Samira's sewing in it, and took out two pillow covers she had made, a pair, black linen embroidered in red silk in the old Ramallah stitch, cross by cross, with the palm tree that the Ramallah women used to put on the backs of their dresses. Samira had worked on them for a whole winter in 1979 at the counter of the store on Broadway between customers. He wrapped them in a clean dish towel and had Sami drive him downtown.

Avis Nance was at the desk. He laid them in front of her.

Among us, he said, *a teacher has to get what is due to a teacher. Otherwise it is a shame on the student. Please. Take them. They're from my wife.*

She was not supposed to take gifts. She looked at the palm trees for a long time with her glasses on and touched one with a finger, and took them. She said thank you. She said they were the most beautiful things anybody had ever brought to that desk. Then she reached into a drawer and took out a blank library card and asked him his address, and wrote it on the form, Hanna's address in Farragut, and asked him to sign, and he signed, and she ran the card through the machine and handed it to him.

He turned it over in his fingers. He had been in Knoxville fifty-six years and he had never had one.

Now you belong here, said Avis Nance. *Anything you want to know, you come here, and we'll find it.*

He put the card in his wallet in front of his driver's license, where Samira's picture used to be, behind it.

My sons feed me three times a day now, and they bring me coffee in the afternoon, he said. *Four times. Two of those I am giving to you. You don't have to cook. You come and eat in the stores, any of them, any day. It's yours.*

She laughed, for the first time since he had known her.

All right, Mr. Musleh, she said. *But I'll go where I want to go.*

• • •

Elias went home and told his sons. *The woman at the library is my friend. I gave her two of my meals. When she comes into the stores, you treat her right.*

Yes, Yaba.

She came into the store on Broadway the next Tuesday at a quarter past twelve, in her library lanyard, and Hanna saw her at the hot case and knew who she was from his father's telling, and came around the counter himself, which he did not do for anyone, and gave her the chicken that had just come out of the fryer and two spinach pies and a sweet tea, and would not let her pay. On Wednesday she was at Issa's on Chapman Highway. On Thursday at Fadi's on Clinton Highway. On Friday at Sami's on Magnolia, where Lisa was working the register, and Lisa came around the counter too and said, *You're the one,* and held her hand.

VI. Red Eggs

Orthodox Easter · April 24, 2022

Easter came late that year for the Orthodox, a week after the American one, and the week before it Hanna came into his father's room and sat on the end of the bed.

Yaba, Easter. Who should we have? Whose honor is it this year? You choose.

The woman at the library is my friend, said Elias. *I don't know anybody else.*

Then invite her. Her and her people. Whoever she wants. We'll set up in the yard.

Avis Nance came at two o'clock on Easter afternoon, in a yellow dress and a hat, and she brought her people, which was not what Hanna had expected. She brought the men from the second floor. Eleven of them, then fourteen, as a second car came up the drive: the men who slept at the mission and spent their days on the benches by the windows, the one with the disability check, the one who had been in the Army with somebody in Detroit, the one with the dog. Some of them had borrowed shirts. Elias knew every one of them by name, and they knew him, and they called him Pops in front of his sons.

The four sons had rented tables and white cloths and set them up on the lawn by the pool, under the willow oaks, with the cover off the pool now and the water blue. There was a lamb Fadi had been roasting since four in the morning, and rice with pine nuts, and a bowl of eggs dyed red the way they are always dyed for Easter, and trays of the date cookies the women made every year for the feast, pressed in the carved wooden molds that had come from Ramallah in somebody's suitcase sixty years ago. The wives served. Rula served. She served Avis Nance first and the man with the dog second, and nobody had to tell her to.

They cracked the red eggs, end against end, around the tables. *Christ is risen. Truly he is risen.* The men from the second floor learned it in Arabic by the third egg and said it back and laughed.

In the middle of the meal the four sons came and pulled their chairs up across the table from Avis Nance, all in a row, with their father at the end of the row in the best chair, in a new shirt, with his beard trimmed and his color back and the cane hooked over the back of the chair behind him.

Ms. Nance, Hanna said. *We take care of our father now. We don't neglect him. Not one day. Just look at him.*

Avis Nance looked at him.

You did good, she said. *People were taking care of their mothers and their fathers a long time before you came along, though.* She put down her fork. *You want me to tell you about one?*

They said yes. She told it.

In the summer of 1967, she said, when she was eleven years old, there was a store on Gay Street downtown that belonged to a Ramallah family, with a candy counter in the front and a lunch counter in the back, and a young man from over there working behind it who could not have been more than twenty-one or twenty-two. He was tall and very thin and had a mustache he was trying to grow. And that June there was a war, over there, six days, and the radio said Ramallah had been taken, and after that the young man could not get any word from home. There were no telephones. The letters did not come. He had a mother there. He had come over in the fall before to work and to send money home, and his mother was there by herself, and he could not get back to her, because when the war was over and they counted the people, if you were not there to be counted you could not go home to live. So he could not go home. And he could not hear if she was alive.

And that boy stopped eating, said Avis Nance. *Every day the lady who owned that store made him a lunch, a bologna sandwich, or some of that bread with the spice on it, and set it on the counter for him, and he would not touch it. He couldn't. He said his stomach would not let it in. He stood behind that counter all day and sold candy to children and would not eat one bite. And every day at noon I came in for a nickel's worth of candy, and he gave me his lunch. All summer. He would wrap it back up in its paper and hand it to me across the counter and say, You eat it. You eat it for me. I ate that boy's lunch every day for six weeks. I've never forgotten it. I used to watch him get thinner. And in August a letter came, and his mother was alive, and he read it standing at the candy counter, and he cried out loud in front of everybody, and then he sat down on a stool behind the counter and ate a whole sandwich, and I didn't get any lunch that day.*

Nobody at the table said anything.

She lived another nine years, said Avis Nance. *He sent her money every month of it. Every month. I know because he used to buy the money orders at the post office on Main Street when I was in high school, and I would see him in the line. He never did get to go back and live there. They wouldn't let him. But she never wanted for a thing.*

She picked her fork back up.

So, she said. *You did good. But you're not the first. That's all I'm saying.*

Elias had his hand over his eyes. Hanna's face was wet, and Issa's, and Fadi had walked off toward the pool and stood with his back to the table, and Sami had his head down on his arms. Rula was crying into a paper napkin. Lisa, who had not understood any of it until that moment and then understood all of it, went around the table and knelt by her father-in-law's chair and put her arms around him. The men from the second floor looked at their plates. One of them, the one with the dog, wiped his face on his borrowed sleeve and said, *Lord, Pops.*

Then Avis Nance said what was on the third slip, the one she had not given him in January, because she had been saving it. She said it to the four sons, quietly, across the red eggs.

> *By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat; and wept when we remembered Sion. We hung our harps on the willows in the midst of it. For there they that had taken us captive asked of us the words of a song; and they that had carried us away asked a hymn, saying, Sing us one of the songs of Sion. How should we sing the Lord's song in a strange land?*
>
> *— Psalm 136:1–4 (Septuagint)*

• • •

Later, when the sun had gone down behind the willow oaks and the men from the second floor had been driven back downtown with foil packages of lamb on their knees, and the tables were folded, and Avis Nance had gone home with a tin of date cookies, Rula went into the house without anyone asking her and came back out with the oud.

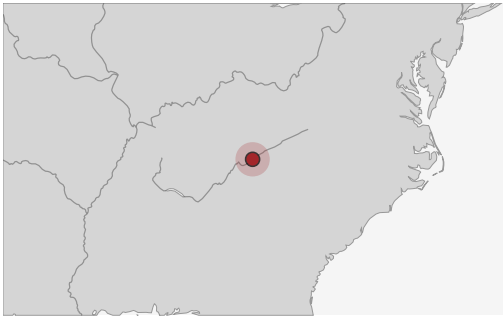
Elias sat with it a long time in the best chair by the pool. He tuned it, string by string, which took a while, because it had been thirty years. Then he played something, not very well, a song from home that nobody under sixty at that table knew. His sons sat around him on the folding chairs in the dark and listened. The cane hung from the back of his chair by its crook, forgotten, its rubber foot just off the grass, turning a little whenever he leaned into a note.

Background

The verse

> *The elephant called Dhanapalaka, his temples running with sap, and difficult to hold, does not eat a morsel when bound; the elephant longs for the elephant grove.*
>
> Dhammapada 324, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich old Brahmin of Sāvatthī with four sons is widowed. Afraid he will remarry and the fortune will be divided, the sons wait on him, rub his hands and feet, and talk him into handing over everything he has. Each daughter-in-law in turn drives him from her door ("Don't you know the way to your other sons' houses?"), and the old man ends up begging with a bowl and a staff. Hearing that the Buddha greets strangers kindly, he goes to him, and the Buddha teaches him verses to recite when the Brahmins assemble with his sons among them; the verses praise the staff that keeps off bulls and dogs above ungrateful children. The law of the day is that a son who eats his parents' wealth and will not support them is put to death. The sons fall at their father's feet, he pleads for them, and they carry him home in a chair. Restored, he brings the Buddha a pair of cloths as a teacher's due and gives him two of his four daily meals; the Buddha says he will go where he pleases, and goes to each son's house in turn. At a feast the sons boast of how well they now care for their father, and the Buddha tells of the elephant Dhanapālaka, who, captured by a king, would not eat for longing for his blind mother in the forest. His hearers weep. Read the full commentary story.



Knoxville, Tennessee

Ramallah and Knoxville, 1967–2022

Ramallah, north of Jerusalem, was founded as a Christian town, and its Greek Orthodox Church of the Transfiguration dates from 1852. Ramallah merchants began emigrating to the United States in 1901, and by the 1950s about a quarter of its natives had left; the American Federation of Ramallah, Palestine was founded in Detroit

in 1959 and still has local clubs from Jacksonville to San Jose. In Knoxville, as the historian Jack Neely has written, a few Christian families from Ramallah were living on Gay Street by 1927. The women of Ramallah once embroidered a palm-tree motif in cross-stitch on the backs of their dresses. Israel took Ramallah in the June 1967 war. Its census of the occupied territories that September left out at least 270,000 Palestinians who were abroad or had fled, and many were later refused the right to return to live, as Human Rights Watch has documented.

The Lawson McGhee Library on Church Avenue, founded in 1885, is the oldest continuously operating public library in Tennessee. For most of its history it served only white patrons; Black Knoxvillians used a separate Free Colored Library, opened in 1918 with Carnegie money, which closed in 1961. The Orthodox churches read the Old Testament in the Greek Septuagint, whose psalm numbers run one behind the Hebrew Bible's (its Psalm 136 is "By the rivers of Babylon"), and the Septuagint's Proverbs differs in places from the Hebrew text. The scripture here is from Lancelot Brenton's English translation, first published in 1844. In 2022 Orthodox Easter fell on April 24, a week after the Western date, and the date cookies of the feast, ma'amoul, are still pressed in carved wooden molds.

After the story of the old Brahmin's sons from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 324). The original. Scripture from the Septuagint in the translation of Sir Lancelot Brenton (1844). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.4

The Hog Extra

Not to satiate one's self with food is the science of health.
— Louis Cornaro, The Art of Living Long (1903)

The way I heard it, at the Oakmere depot.

I. The Day Book

Agent's day book, Oakmere station, C.B.&Q.: January 1926

JAN. 11, MONDAY. COLD. 4 ABOVE AT 6:00. LIT THE WAITING-room stove 5:40. Hog extra east 7:38, forty-one cars, steaming like a laundry. No. 22 on time 7:52, took 63 commuters. Sold 9 monthly commutation books. Mr. H. Dunning, village president, came down at 7:30 and walked the platform the whole length three times and sat down on the bench by the baggage truck with his mouth open and missed the 7:52. Sent him in on the 8:20. He said, *I don't know what's the matter with me, Mrs. Sandquist.* I know what's the matter with him. Ham, eggs, fried potatoes, buckwheat cakes, sausage, a bowl of oats with the top of the milk on it. His cook told my niece.

JAN. 12. Same. Caught the 7:52 this time but it took the brakeman to boost him.

JAN. 14. Mr. Dunning came into the office after the 7:52 had gone without him and asked could he sit a minute. I said sit. He sat in my chair by the key and his eyes went shut and his head went down on his chest and the sounder went on clacking and he did not hear it. I let him. At 8:05 he woke up and looked around like a man coming up out of a well.

Did you come down before you were rested, Mr. Dunning?

No, I slept eight hours. It's after I eat. Every day of my life, after I eat, I feel like this.

Well, I said, *that's what eating like that will do. It always does.*

He looked at me. I am sixty-seven and have been agent here since 1894, when the job was Carl's and Carl died and the division superintendent let me keep the key because I could send faster than Carl and everyone knew it. Mr. Dunning was in short pants then. I have sold him every ticket he ever bought.

The hog extra was standing on the passing track waiting for No. 24 to clear, the way it does two mornings in five. I pointed at it with my pencil.

You see those, I said. *Corn-fed. Eat and lie down and roll over and eat. That car goes in to the Yards this morning and tomorrow morning there's another one standing in the same place, and I declare it's the same hogs. Thirty-two years I've watched it. It's always the same hogs, going around.*

He did not like that. He went out and stood on the platform with his hands in his coat. But he did not go up the street either. He stood and watched the extra pull out, forty-one cars, every slat with a snout in it, all the way out of sight toward Chicago.

JAN. 15. 2 below. Pipe in the ladies' room froze. No. 22 eight minutes late, ice at Aurora.

II. The Blanks

The same book · January and February

JAN. 18. THE DUNNING BOY, WALTER, 13, HAS BEEN COMING IN after school since Thanksgiving to learn the key. I let him sit at the dead one and practice. He is slow on his numbers and fast on his letters, which is backwards. Today I took down the book that was in lost-and-found when I came here, which nobody ever claimed and which I have read through four times: *The Art of Living Long*, by Louis Cornaro, a Venetian gentleman who ate himself nearly to death by forty and then stopped, and lived to be past a hundred. Printed in Milwaukee, 1903. Somebody left it on the 5:14.

I copied a piece of it on a yellow message blank in my best hand, the way I would take down a telegram, and gave it to Walter.

Every time your father sits down to eat, I said, *you read him this. After the blessing. Before he takes a bite. Breakfast and supper and Sunday dinner. Every time.*

He won't like it.

He didn't like the hogs either.

> *In this manner, I accustomed myself to the habit of never fully satisfying my appetite, either with eating or drinking—always leaving the table well able to take more. In this I acted according to the proverb: "Not to satiate one's self with food is the science of health."*
>
> *— Louis Cornaro, The Art of Living Long (Milwaukee, 1903)*

JAN. 19. Walter says he read it. Says his mother laughed and his father put down his fork and asked who was Louis Cornaro, and Walter said a Venetian, and his father said that figures, and ate his supper anyhow. All of it.

JAN. 20. Walter read it again at breakfast. Mr. D. came down for the 7:52 and did not look at the office window.

JAN. 23. Read it again. And again. Walter says it is like saying grace twice. He has it by heart now and does not need the blank, but I told him to read it off the blank anyway. A message is a message.

FEB. 2. Walter reports his father left two buckwheat cakes on the plate this morning. Did not say anything about it. Left them.

FEB. 9. Gave Walter a second blank. The first one is worn through at the folds.

> *And I do not feel like sleeping; for the small amount of food I take cannot make me drowsy, as it is insufficient to send fumes from the stomach to the head.*
>
> *— Louis Cornaro, The Art of Living Long (Milwaukee, 1903)*

FEB. 16. Mr. D. caught the 7:52 without the brakeman. Said good morning to me through the window, first time this year.

FEB. 24. Snow, 9 inches. Section men out at 4:00 on the switches. Mr. D. came down at 7:15, early, and took a broom off the baggage room wall

and swept the platform from one end to the other before anybody asked him. The village president. I wrote it down so somebody would believe it.

III. Weights and Measures

The same book · spring and summer

APR. 6. MR. D. WEIGHED HIMSELF ON THE BAGGAGE SCALE while the 7:52 was whistling for the crossing. 214. He was 241 at Christmas, he says. He wrote it on the wall by the scale in pencil, which I do not allow, and I let it stay.

APR. 20. Walter got his numbers. Sent 25 words a minute clean.

MAY 4. The breakfast at the Dunnings' is one bowl of oats, the boy says. One bowl and a cup of coffee, and the cook is put out and says she does not know what she is in that kitchen for.

JUNE 22. Hot. The Rebekahs' picnic. Mr. D. stood on the platform an hour with me in the heat helping the old ladies off the 8:20 with their baskets, and laughed at something one of them said, a big laugh, and I could not remember ever hearing him laugh before.

AUG. 6. Over the wire in the afternoon: the Ederle girl swam the English Channel, first woman ever, beat the men's time. Mr. D. came off the 5:14 and I read it to him off the blank and he took off his hat and threw it up in the air on the platform, at his age, and it came down on the track, and Walter went down and got it.

AUG. 27. 192 on the baggage scale. Cornaro says when he left the table he had to sing. Mr. D. has gone back into the choir at the Methodist church. Second bass. His wife told my niece.

IV. Fight Night

The same book · September 23

SEPT. 23. RAIN HERE AND RAIN IN PHILADELPHIA. DEMPSEY and Tunney for the title. Half the men in the village have radios and the other half came down to the depot because the Western Union was carrying the rounds and I would read them out through the window. Forty-

SOME MEN ON THE PLATFORM UNDER UMBRELLAS AND IN THE waiting room. Somebody brought a washtub of sandwiches from the lodge hall, ham and cheese, and a dishpan of doughnuts.

Mr. D. stood at the window with the others. Every round I read out, the tub went around. He took one sandwich at the first round and ate it slow. The tub came around nine more times and he let it go by nine times, and said *no thank you* nine times, and I counted, because I count everything, it is my job.

Tunney took it on points, ten rounds. Dempsey's eye shut. The men went home in the rain arguing. Mr. D. stayed and helped Walter carry the empty tub back up to the lodge hall, the two of them under one umbrella, and I heard them singing going up Burlington Avenue, something from the hymnal, the boy flat.

V. Christmas Week

The same book · December 24–31

DEC. 24. 6:10 A.M. MR. D. CAME DOWN IN THE DARK WITH THE Methodist church's big coffee urn on a coaster wagon, and Walter pulling, and three dozen doughnuts from Kuhn's bakery in two boxes, and set up on a sawhorse table under the depot light. Every man who came for the 7:52 got a cup, and every man for the 8:20. The section men. The brakemen off the hog extra, who stood there steaming in the cold with their cups. A man off the freight who had been riding the rods since Ottumwa, and Mr. D. gave him three doughnuts and his own gloves. 186 on the scale.

DEC. 25. Christmas. No commuters. He came down anyway and the urn went to the section gang and the switch tender and me, and a family going to Galesburg on No. 9 with four children asleep on the bench.

DEC. 26, 27, 28. Every morning. Six o'clock. The urn, the wagon, the doughnuts.

DEC. 29. Mrs. Dunning came down with him and poured. People are coming to the 7:52 who take the 8:20 as a rule, just to have the coffee and

stand under the light with the village president in his old overcoat, which hangs on him now like a horse blanket.

DEC. 30. 12 below. He brought a second urn.

DEC. 31. Seventh day. At 8:25, when the 8:20 had gone, he came to the window and wanted to give me something for my trouble, an envelope. I told him the Q pays me. He said then what can I do for you. I told him he could put the urn away clean and the wagon back where he found it, and he did, and Walter swept up the sugar.

Then I gave Walter the third blank. I had been saving it.

> *They also see how I am ever cheerful, happy, and contented—free from all perturbations of the soul and from every vexatious thought; instead of these, joy and peace have fixed their abode in my heart, and never depart from it.*
>
> *— Louis Cornaro, The Art of Living Long (Milwaukee, 1903)*

Year's business, Oakmere: 11,904 tickets, 1,131 commutation books, 2,217 messages sent and received. Hog extras, 263.

VI. A Man I Admire

Composition, Grade 8, Oakmere School · January 1927

A MAN I ADMIRE. BY WALTER DUNNING.

The man I admire is my father, Mr. Harold Dunning, who is the president of the village, but that is not why. Last year he was sick every day after breakfast and went to sleep on the bench and the brakeman had to boost him up on the train. That is true. You can ask the brakeman. His name is Mr. Riordan.

Mrs. Sandquist at the depot wrote down something from a book by a man from Venice for me to read to my father before every meal. I read it to him 900 times about. I counted the meals. At first he said every time, Thank you, Walter, in a voice. Then after a while he said it in his regular voice. Then in the summer he started saying it with me. He knows it by

heart now and so does my mother and so does the cook, Hilda, though she says it does her no good, she is not the one.

My father lost 55 pounds. He sings bass. On fight night he only ate one sandwich. At Christmas he gave coffee to everybody at the depot for seven days including a tramp who got his gloves. Mother says he is a different man but he says no, he is the same man, only less of him.

The reason I admire him is it is hard to leave food on your plate when it is right there. I know because I tried it.

Mrs. Sandquist says when I am sixteen I can be her night operator. She says I am still slow on numbers.

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Agent's day book · January 3, 1927

JAN. 3. 10 ABOVE. HOG EXTRA EAST 7:36, THIRTY-EIGHT CARS. Walter brought back the three blanks, folded soft as cloth, the first one in two pieces. He said his father does not need them read anymore. I put them in the book at the page where they came from and put the book back on the lost-and-found shelf over the stove, for the next one.

Background

The verse

> *If a man becomes fat and a great eater, if he is sleepy and rolls himself about, that fool, like a hog fed on wash, is born again and again.*
>
> Dhammapada 325, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi of Kosala goes through a period of eating rice by the bucketful, with sauce and curry to match. One morning after breakfast he comes to the Buddha so heavy with sleep that he paces wearily and then sits down to one side. The Buddha asks whether he has come before he was rested; the king says he always suffers after a meal, and the Buddha answers that overeating always brings suffering, and speaks the verse of the fat man rolling in his sleep like a great hog fed on fodder. Then he teaches a second verse, on knowing the measure in food so that one ages slowly and guards one's life, to a young Brahmin named Uttara, and tells him to recite it whenever the king sits down to eat. In time the king is content with a

pint-pot of rice, grows lean and cheerful, and gives incomparable gifts for seven days. The commentary tells nearly the same episode under verse 204 (story 15.6). Read the full commentary story.

Oakmere (fictional), a Burlington-line suburb west of Chicago, Illinois

The Burlington suburbs, *1926*

The Chicago, Burlington and Quincy ran its commuter trains from the new Union Station, opened in 1925, west through a string of railroad suburbs toward Aurora, on the line that is now Metra's BNSF Line. The same tracks carried livestock east from Iowa and Nebraska to the Union Stock Yards, where more meat was processed through the early 1920s than anywhere else on earth. Small stations were kept by an agent-operator who sold tickets, handled freight and express, and worked the telegraph; from the Civil War on, many American telegraphers were women. Oakmere, the Sandquists and the Dunnings are fictional. In 1926 the wire carried Gertrude Ederle's Channel swim on August 6 and, on September 23, Gene Tunney's ten-round decision over Jack Dempsey in the rain at Philadelphia.

Luigi (Alvise) Cornaro, a Paduan who claimed Venetian nobility, wore himself out with eating and drinking by about forty and, on his doctors' advice, cut himself to about twelve ounces of food a day. His *Discorsi della vita sobria*, written from his eighties on, was a great success and was translated into English again and again for four centuries; the edition Mrs. Sandquist finds, *The Art of Living Long*, was published in Milwaukee by William F. Butler in 1903. Prohibition had made liquor the vice good Methodists did without; the table was another matter.

After the story of King Pasenadi of Kosala from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 325). The original. Scripture from Louis Cornaro's *The Art of Living Long* (William F. Butler, Milwaukee, 1903). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.5

Out of the Fire

> *The LORD rebuke thee, O Satan; even the LORD that hath chosen Jerusalem rebuke thee: is not this a brand plucked out of the fire?*
> *— Zechariah 3:2*

So I've heard it told, on Stoner Creek.

I. The Log

Cane Ridge, Bourbon County, Kentucky · August 1801

Sandy Combs fell on the Saturday afternoon, in the woods below the meetinghouse.

He was twelve. He had come over from Stoner Creek with his father and his stepmother in the wagon on Friday, with a sack of meal and a side of bacon and two quilts, and by Saturday noon there were more people in the woods at Cane Ridge than he had known there were in Kentucky. Wagons stood in the trees in every direction as far as you could see, and horses tied to every sapling, and fires smoking at every camp. There was preaching at the meetinghouse and preaching at the tent and preaching from wagon beds and stumps. A little way off the colored people had their own preaching. Under all of it was a noise like a river in flood, singing and praying and shouting and crying all at once, and the noise never stopped, not even in the night.

He had been watching people fall since Friday. A man would be standing and singing and then go down in the leaves as if he had been shot, and lie there, and the people around him would kneel and pray over him, and after an hour or two, or sometimes a day, he would get up shouting. Sandy had not been afraid of it. He had been curious about it, the way he

was curious about a snake. On Saturday afternoon he was standing at the edge of a crowd around a Presbyterian on a stump, with his hands in his pockets, when it happened to him. His knees went. He lay in the leaves and could not move his arms, and he heard everything, the preacher and the singing and a dog barking somewhere in the camps, and he could not move at all.

He lay there about an hour. When he got up, he was talking.

Two men he did not know lifted him onto a big walnut log that had been felled for benches, and held him there, one on each side, by the arms, because his legs would not hold him yet, and he exhorted the crowd for most of an hour. Nobody afterward could remember all of what he said. They remembered the voice. It was a boy's voice, high and clear, before it broke, and it went out over that whole roaring woods somehow and was heard on the far side of it. People came from the meetinghouse to hear it. He told them that Christ was willing. He told them not to wait. He took a handkerchief out of his pocket and held it up over his head and let it drop, and told them that was how short the time was. And every little while he would stop and put out both his hands to the crowd and say, *Come on, sinners. Come on in.*

Then the men let go of his arms, and he sat down on the log in the dusk and cried.

His stepmother, Rachel, had him by then. She wrapped him in a quilt in the back of the wagon, and he lay against her with his teeth chattering, and the last thing he said before he went to sleep was a thing he would say after every meeting for the next six years.

Whatever good there was in that, he said, *let it go to my mother and my pa.*

Rachel thought he meant her, and she was glad of it, and she said so to nobody.

II. The Two Mothers

Stoner Creek · 1791–1806

His own mother was named Hannah, and she had burned to death when he was two.

It was in the winter of 1791, in the first cabin his father put up on the creek, the year they came over the mountains. His father was off at the salt lick. The chimney was sticks and clay, the way they all were then, and it caught in the night, and the roof went in before anybody knew. Rachel Ferrell was sixteen and lived on the next place down. She saw the light and ran up the creek in her shift, and she went into that cabin through the fire and came out with the baby, and went back in for his mother and could not find her, and came out the second time with her hair burning. She put her hair out in the creek. Then she sat on the bank holding the boy against her until his father came home.

Jesse Combs married her the next year. She raised the boy as her own, and they never had any of their own after, and Sandy called her Mama all his life. His mother Hannah was buried under a big sycamore by the creek with a fieldstone at her head. He did not remember her. He used to go and sit on the stone.

After Cane Ridge, Brother Amos Tull took him up.

Brother Tull was a Methodist local preacher, an old man with a farm on Hinkston Creek and a red bull that was known in three counties for its temper. He had been converted in Virginia under Asbury's preachers before the war with England, and he had been preaching ever since, on Sundays, in barns and cabins and under trees, without pay, and farming the rest of the week. He was not a loud preacher. He said a thing once, in few words, and then sat down, and it was usually the thing you were still thinking about at supper. He asked Jesse and Rachel whether the boy could come with him to the meetings. The quarterly meeting gave Sandy a paper that let him exhort. He was the youngest on the circuit, and for five years he went everywhere Brother Tull went.

There was a great deal of meeting in Kentucky in those years. The fire that had started at Cane Ridge ran down the country like fire in a cane brake, and there were camp meetings every summer in every county. On a meeting day Sandy would be up before light. He swept the ground in front of the preaching stand with a cedar bush. He carried the split logs for the benches and set them in their rows. At dusk he built up the fires on the stands at the corners of the ground so there would be light for the

night preaching. Then, when everything was ready, he stood up on the end of a bench and called the people in, and that voice, which was still a boy's voice for a long time, went out over the creek bottoms and the camps and the horse lines, and people came.

Come on in, sinners. Come and hear. Come on in.

The preachers liked to have him exhort after the sermon, and they asked him often, and he never once said he was tired or that his throat hurt, though sometimes it did. He would get up on the end of the bench and the people would go still. Some said it was like water coming down out of the sky. And every time, when he got down, he said the same thing, to Brother Tull or to the bench or to nobody. *Whatever good there was in that, let it go to my mother and my pa.*

What Rachel never knew, and Jesse never knew, was who else was listening.

The old women of Stoner Creek knew it, or said they did. At the meetings, they said, the dead came too. You did not see them unless you were looking at the edge of the light, past the last fire, where the trees started, and then you might see them standing there in rows among the trunks, quiet, listening to the preaching the way the living did. And when Sandy Combs got up to exhort, there was always one of them who came up nearer than the rest, a young woman in a grey dress with her hair cut off short as if it had been burned. The old women knew who she was. They said the others made room for her. They said that among the dead she was given the front of the bench, and the first of the light, and that even the old dead, the ones who had been preachers themselves and had been dead since before the Revolution, would step back out of the path when Hannah Combs came by, because of her boy. And after he said what he always said, about letting it go to his mother, the old women said they heard her answer him. *Thank you, son. I have it.*

This was told on Stoner Creek for many years, by people who had not been at the meetings and by people who had.

III. The Chair

The Combs place on Stoner Creek · March 1807

By the spring of 1807 Sandy Combs was eighteen years old and as tall as his father, and his voice had broken long ago, and something in him had broken with it.

The meetings were not what they had been. Barton Stone and some of the other revival preachers had left the Presbyterians and called themselves only Christians, and a few had gone up into Ohio to the Shakers, who danced and did not marry. Nobody held up children on logs to exhort anymore. People said it had been a disorder. Sandy was too big to stand on the end of a bench and too young to be a preacher, and he went around with Brother Tull carrying logs and building fires and calling people in, and he found that he did not want to do it. He wanted other things. He did not always know what they were. A piece of land in the Green River country. A horse that could run at the Lexington races. A girl in Paris named Polly Ritchie, whose father kept a still. His own house, with a door that shut, and nobody standing on the end of a bench in it. The thoughts went every way at once, like cattle out of a broken lot, and he could not get them back in, and he quit trying.

He did not tell Brother Tull. One morning in March, with his hair grown down over his collar and his nails long and black and his one shirt filthy, he took his saddlebags and walked the eleven miles home alone.

Rachel saw him coming up the creek road. She came out and stood in the yard with her hands in her apron.

You always come with Brother Tull, she said. *Or with one of the young men. What are you doing coming home by yourself?*

He told her. He said he was done with it. He said he meant to stay home and work and get some land of his own and marry, and that was all he wanted, and he didn't want to talk about it.

She talked about it anyway. She stood in the yard in the cold and told him what the world was. She told him about men she had known who had wanted land and got it and the land had eaten them alive, and men who had wanted whiskey, and men who had gone to the races and come back

without their horses and their farms, and his own grandfather, who had died in a debtor's prison in Virginia. She talked for a long time, and he stood there with the saddlebags on his shoulder and listened to all of it and looked at the ground, and she saw that it was not going in.

So she stopped. *Maybe he'll come to it by himself,* she thought, *if I let him alone.*

Come in the house, she said. *You're hungry. I'll get you some buttermilk and cornbread, and when you've eaten I'll get down your pa's good shirt and you can put it on and I'll wash that one.*

She set the chair for him by the hearth, the good chair, the one with the hide seat, and he sat down in it. She brought him the buttermilk and the cornbread and he ate. Then she took a pan of dried beans out to the doorstep, where the light was better, and sat down there to pick them over for supper, a few feet from him, with her back half to him, so that he would not feel watched.

What happened next she told many times afterward, always the same way.

She heard the chair go over. She turned around and he was on the floor of the cabin on his back. His head was jerking back and forth, hard, the way she had seen people jerk at the meetings, so hard you could hear his hair whip on the boards. His eyes had rolled up white. There was froth on his mouth. His heels drummed on the floor and his hands were clawed up at his chest.

She threw the beans down and went to him. She got him up off the floor somehow, half into her lap, and held his head against her breast so it would stop hitting the boards, and she screamed for Jesse, who was in the far field. Jesse came running, and the Gaithers from the next place, white and colored, from their field, and a man who had been passing on the road with a mule, and in a little while there were a dozen people in the yard and in the door.

Rachel sat on the floor holding him and rocking, and said it out loud, to all of them and to nobody.

They told us at the meetings that the devil can't lay a hand on them that keep the Sabbath, she said. *Them that pray in secret and keep themselves*

clean. I heard the preachers say it. I heard it a hundred times. And look at him. Look what's got hold of him.

Then Sandy spoke. His eyes were still rolled up and his body was still pulling in her arms, but his mouth was moving, and the voice that came out of it was not his. It was a woman's voice, low and even and tired, a young woman's. Rachel did not know it. Old Mrs. Gaither, who was standing in the door, put her hand over her own mouth, because she did. She had sat up with that voice through a lying-in in 1789.

It's so, the voice said. *What they told you is so. They heard it right.*

The voice spoke to the boy then, as if he were across the room.

Sandy. Don't turn your back on him. Don't do wrong, son, in the open or in the dark either one. If you do it, now or after, you'll not get shut of it. You can take the wings of the morning and you'll not get shut of it. Be sure your sin will find you out.

Then the boy went limp in Rachel's arms, as if somebody had set him down.

He opened his eyes after a little while. He looked up at her, and at her hair, which had come down, and at her face, which was wet, and at all the people in the yard and the door, and at the chair lying on its side.

Mama, he said, *I was sitting in the chair. You were on the step with the beans. How'd I get down here?*

Nobody answered him.

He sat up. He looked at her a long time.

Mama, what are you crying for? People cry for the dead. Or somebody gone off where they won't see him again. I'm not dead. I'm right here.

Rachel wiped her face with the heel of her hand.

They cry for the dead, she said. *They cry for the ones that go off and don't come back. And they cry for the one that was dead and come alive again, and then goes back and dies a second time. That one they cry for the most. That's who I'm crying for.*

He did not say anything.

I'll tell you something you never heard the whole of, she said. *When you were two years old your mother's house burned down with her in it, and I went in after you. I went in through the fire and got you out of the bed and carried*

you out of there. I didn't have time to get anything else. There wasn't anything else. I carried you out like you'd carry the one thing out of a burning house that you could save. And now you're grown, and you want to walk back in.

She took his face in both her hands.

There's fire on both sides of you, she said. *Do you want to go back in it? Is that what you want? Lord, help us. Who else have I got to tell it to? Here's a brand plucked out of the fire, and he wants to go back in the fire.*

The people in the yard were quiet. Jesse had his hat in his hands. The man with the mule had taken off his.

Sandy looked at her for a long time. Then he looked at the hearth.

No, ma'am, he said. *I don't want it.*

She let go of his face. *Good,* she said. *Good.*

She set the chair back up on its legs and set him in it. She took the beans back out to the step and picked them up off the ground, every one, and she cooked them for supper with the last of the side meat and set the whole pot in front of him, and he ate it. When he had eaten, she asked him how old he was. She knew. She asked anyway.

Eighteen, he said. *This month.*

That's old enough, she said.

That night she took down the bolt of black wool she had been keeping for her own burying and cut him out a coat. It took her a week, sitting up by the fire. Jesse traded a heifer for a horse, a short-legged bay that would go all day. Old Mrs. Gaither gave him a pair of saddlebags that had been her husband's. That fall Brother Tull took him to the Western Conference, and the conference admitted him on trial as a traveling preacher and sent him out on a circuit across the Green River, where he had once meant to buy land, with a Bible and a hymnbook and the black coat, and eighty dollars a year if anybody ever paid it.

IV. The Ring

Brother Tull's place on Hinkston Creek · August 1807

BEFORE HE LEFT FOR THE CONFERENCE, HE WENT TO SEE Brother Tull.

The old man was in the lot behind his barn with the red bull. It was August and the bull was in a temper because of the Gaither cows in the next field. He was bellowing and throwing his head and pawing up the ground, and the lather stood on his neck. Brother Tull had a hickory staff in his hand, about six feet long, with an iron hook at the end of it, and the hook was through the brass ring in the bull's nose. He was walking the bull around the lot, slowly, at the end of the staff, and every time the bull flung his head toward the fence the old man gave the staff a little turn, not much, and the bull's head came back around.

Sandy stood at the fence and watched. The bull was a ton of meat and Brother Tull was seventy-one years old and weighed about as much as a sack of meal.

After a while Brother Tull walked the bull into his stall and shut it in and hung the staff on two pegs on the wall of the barn, and came over and leaned on the fence beside him.

I heard about what happened at your mama's, he said.

Sandy said he expected the whole county had.

Brother Tull looked out over the lot.

You've had a mind that went wherever it pleased for a long time, he said. *Since you were a boy. It went to the meetings because it pleased it to go. It went to the Ritchie girl and the races because that pleased it better. It's a strong mind. It's like that one.* He nodded at the barn, where the bull was still blowing. *You can't reason with him, this time of year. You can't hope he'll behave. You don't let go of the ring, that's all. Not for a step. You'll get tired of holding it. Hold it anyhow. It gets to where you don't notice you're holding it, after about thirty years.*

That was all he said about it. Then he went into the house and came out with his Bible and opened it on the top rail of the fence and turned it around so Sandy could read, and put his finger on the verse, and Sandy read it out loud.

> *Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ.*
>
> *— 2 Corinthians 10:5*

Every thought, Brother Tull said. *Not just the bad ones. All of them.*

He took the staff down off the pegs and gave it to him to take along.

The old women of Stoner Creek said that the young woman in the grey dress came to one more meeting after that. It was the camp meeting on Hinkston Creek that September, the last before Sandy went to the conference, and Brother Tull preached, and Sandy did not exhort, but only built the fires and called the people in. They said she stood at the edge of the light among the others all through the preaching, and that when it was over and the last hymn was sung, she turned and looked at the others with her, all of the dead along the edge of the trees, as if something had come clear to her that she had wanted to know for a long time, and they looked back at her the same way. Then they went off into the dark together. Nobody on Stoner Creek ever saw her again.

V. The Staff

Missouri · 1882

He rode circuits for fifty-four years: across the Green River country, through Tennessee and southern Indiana and Illinois, and at the last in Missouri, where he settled in Boone County and preached until he could not get up on a horse. He was ordained deacon and then elder, and he read everything that came over the mountains, so that the young preachers called him the Library. He married once, late, and buried her. He held something like four thousand meetings in his life, by his own count, and at every one of them, as long as he could stand, he was the one who stood up at the beginning and called the people in. He never could make himself say it any other way.

Come on in, sinners. Come on in.

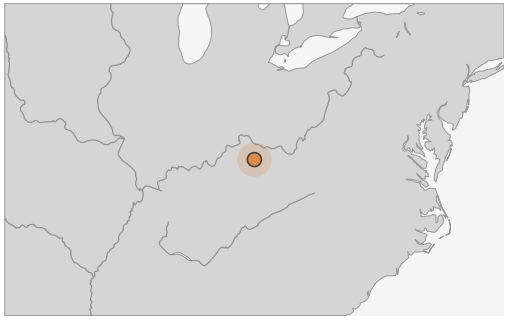
He died in 1882, at ninety-three, in a chair by a hearth in Columbia, Missouri. Rachel had been dead forty years by then. On the wall over the chair, on two pegs, hung a hickory staff about six feet long with an iron hook at the end of it, worn black and smooth at the place where his hand had been.

Background

The verse

> *This mind of mine went formerly wandering about as it liked, as it listed, as it pleased; but I shall now hold it in thoroughly, as the rider who holds the hook holds in the furious elephant.*
>
> Dhammapada 326, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the novice Sāṇu has a voice so fine that the monks keep asking him to chant, and he never once pleads a sore heart or a tired body; every time, he gives the merit of it to his mother and father. His parents in this life do not know it, but his mother from his previous life, now a *yakkhinī*, a spirit, comes with the gods to listen and receives it, and the spirits honor her with the first seat for his sake. Grown to manhood, Sāṇu turns discontented and goes home alone, unkempt, meaning to give up the robe. His mother argues with him and fails, then sits him down and goes to wash rice for him. The yakkhinī seizes him; he falls foaming and twisting, the village gathers, and his mother laments that spirits are said not to touch those who keep the holy days. Through him the spirit answers: do no evil, openly or in secret, for there is no flying away from it. He wakes and asks why she weeps for a living man. She answers that people weep for one who, though living, has died again, and that she snatched him like goods out of a burning house and he wants to burn again. He gives up the plan, and she provides his robes for full ordination. The Buddha tells him to master his wandering mind as an elephant driver masters a rutting elephant with the hook. Sāṇu becomes a great teacher and lives to a hundred and twenty. Read the full commentary story.



Cane Ridge, Bourbon County, Kentucky

Kentucky, 1801–1807

The Cane Ridge revival in Bourbon County, in August 1801, drew between ten and twenty-five thousand people to a Presbyterian sacramental meeting hosted by Barton Stone. Presbyterian and Methodist preachers spoke from the meetinghouse, a tent and stumps and logs at once; Black worshippers held their own preaching; and thousands fell in the "falling exercise," some lying motionless for hours, while others were seized by "the jerks." Children who had fallen and risen were allowed to exhort, sometimes held up by grown men: one boy of about twelve, at Indian Creek that June, exhorted from a log for an hour with a man at each arm and lifted a handkerchief and let it fall as a warning to sinners. By 1810 child exhortation had all but disappeared. In 1803 Stone and four other ministers left the Kentucky Synod, and in 1804 they agreed to take no name but Christians; in 1805 the revival preacher Richard McNemar joined the Shakers.

The Methodists turned the revival into a system. A promising convert could receive a permit to exhort from the quarterly meeting; if the meeting recommended him, the annual Western Conference could admit him "on trial" as a traveling preacher and send him to a circuit, on an allowance of eighty dollars a year for a single man, rarely paid in full, as Peter Cartwright remembered of his own start in 1802–1804. The camp meeting born at Cane Ridge spread across the country with them. The Combs family, Brother Tull and the Gaithers are invented; the boy's descendants turn up two centuries later in Sinners Welcome.

After the story of the novice Sāṇu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 326). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.6

The Old Bull

Let each man raise
The Self by Soul, not trample down his Self
— Bhagavad Gita 6:5

Me aam sambhalyu chhe, at the front desk on Highway 70.

I. The Night Desk

Hugo, Oklahoma · spring 1979

The Kiamichi Motor Court had twenty-two rooms in an L around a gravel lot on the east side of Hugo, a sign with a neon arrow that had stopped pointing in 1971, and an ice machine that worked when you kicked it. Navin Patel bought it in the fall of 1976 for forty-one thousand dollars, which was the money his wife's brothers in Leicester had raised, and a little more than the forty thousand the government in Washington wanted to see a man put into a business before it would let him stay. No company in Oklahoma would insure it. No bank in Choctaw County would lend on it. Navin's cousins in Durant and Idabel and Paris, Texas, had put in a thousand here and two thousand there, and he was paying them back a room-night at a time.

He lived behind the office with his wife and their two daughters. His wife cleaned eleven rooms in the morning and Navin cleaned the other eleven. The girls stripped beds after school. And from eleven at night until seven in the morning, Navin's uncle sat at the front desk.

Everyone called him Kaka, which only means uncle. He was seventy. For thirty-four years he had taught English and mathematics at a secondary school in Kampala, and in August of 1972, when the President of Uganda gave the Asians ninety days to leave the country, he had left it,

with one suitcase and his wife's ashes in a brass pot and whatever the soldiers at the roadblocks on the way to Entebbe did not take. Now he sat behind the counter at the Kiamichi Motor Court in a grey cardigan, with a book open under the lamp, and handed keys across to truck drivers and roughnecks and once in a while a family headed for Six Flags, and said *Good night, sir,* in an accent the truck drivers took for English.

On Sunday nights the young men came.

They came from the motels along 70 and 271, in their fathers' cars, after the Sunday check-outs were done and the rooms were turned. Navin's nephew Raju, who had come over from Leicester the year before to work the Kiamichi's day desk and slept on a cot in Room 22. The two Desai brothers from Antlers, who had not spoken to each other since Diwali. Mahesh, who had been an engineering student in Baroda and was now the night man at a motel in Paris, Texas, and hated every hour of it. Bharat from Durant, whose father had just bought a second motel on a note he could not cover. Dinesh, who was nineteen and had been born in Kampala and remembered the roadblocks. Some Sundays there were five of them and some Sundays nine. They sat on the floor of the office on a bedspread from Room 14, with their backs against the soda machine, and drank the tea Navin's wife sent through, and Kaka read the Gita to them.

He read it in English. They had all learned Gujarati at their mothers' knees, but none of them could read the old Sanskrit, and Kaka had a translation from a secondhand bookstall on Kampala Road that he had carried out of Uganda in the suitcase, in place of a second pair of shoes. Mr. Edwin Arnold, 1885. *The Song Celestial.* He read a page, and closed it on his finger, and said very little, and then they talked about the price of gasoline and the price of rooms until midnight, when the truckers started to come in off the Indian Nation Turnpike and he sent them home.

That spring the gasoline was getting short. On the television there were lines of cars around the block in California. The truckers said it would be the same here by summer, and nobody would drive anywhere, and half the motels on Highway 70 would go back to the banks. Across the highway from the Kiamichi Motor Court, the Starlite Motel had put

up a new plywood sign in red, white and blue under its old one. It said AMERICAN OWNED.

II. The Bull

Winter quarters, Kiamichi road

HUGO WAS A CIRCUS TOWN. THREE OR FOUR SHOWS WINTERED there, more some years, and from November to March the fields south and east of town were full of trucks with lettering on their sides, and tigers in steel cages in a tin barn, and camels grazing behind barbed wire along the farm roads like something out of the Bible. In March the shows went out on the road. The trucks pulled out one morning in a long line with their horns going, and the town was quiet again until Thanksgiving.

Not everything went. At the Bradley Brothers quarters on the Kiamichi road, three miles east of the Kiamichi Motor Court, the old animals stayed behind, the ones who could no longer make the jumps. A lion with no teeth. A pony mare who was blind. And Rani.

In a circus every elephant is a bull. Rani was a cow, a female Asian elephant, and the bull men called her the old bull, or Old Lady, or Mama, and she was sixty years old by the best guess anybody had, which made her older than most of them. She had come off a ship in New York before the Depression with a crate number stenciled on her flank. She had worked for six shows under four names. Bradley Brothers had painted RANI on the leather headpiece she wore in the spec, the grand parade that opened every performance, and Kaka, the first time he saw it on a poster in the window of the drugstore, had laughed out loud. It meant queen.

She had been the strongest elephant on any lot in America. That was what the old circus men said about her at the café on the square, and they said it the way men talk about a ballplayer. In the days before the shows went to trucks, when everything traveled on wagons and every lot in the rain was a bog, they had called them mud shows, and Rani had pulled wagons out of the mud. She had pushed the pole wagon out of a slough in Arkansas that eight horses could not move. She had raised the center

pole of a big top by herself in a wind that was laying flat the corn. When the trucks came in, she pushed trucks. For thirty-one years she had led the spec around the hippodrome track with a bull man named Dewey Haskins walking at her head, both of them in costume, to a march played on a brass band and a bass drum the size of a wagon wheel, and the people in the bleachers stood up for her, every night, in every town.

Dewey was seventy-two now. He had bad hips and a pension from nobody. He lived in a trailer at the quarters and fed the old animals and watched the barns at night, and every evening in the spring he walked Rani down the fence line to the pond and back, very slowly, the two of them the same speed now.

III. The Lake

Hugo Lake · a Sunday in May

It rained for five days that May. The Kiamichi came up, and the Corps of Engineers let water out of the dam, and the arms of the lake spread out over the bottomland and then drew back and left behind them a mile of grey mud as smooth as cake icing, with dead trees standing up out of it. On Saturday night a wind came up out of the southwest ahead of a line of storms, and somewhere in the night it took down a section of the old fence on the far side of the quarters.

Dewey found the gap at five in the morning, and her tracks going through it, each one as big around as a washtub and full of rainwater.

She had walked a mile and a half through the timber in the dark and come out on the west arm of the lake and gone down the bank into the water to drink, or to bathe, or for the reason old animals go off by themselves, which nobody ever knows. She had waded out thirty yards. And there, on the flat where the water had been ten feet deep the week before, the mud had taken her. She was down in it past her knees, and then past her belly, and when she tried to swing herself free she only went deeper. By the time Dewey limped out of the trees with the sheriff's deputy behind him, she was standing in the grey muck up to her

shoulders, with her trunk curled up out of the water on the top of her head, not moving at all.

By noon half of Hugo was on the bank. People came out from church in their good clothes and stood under umbrellas, though the rain had stopped. Choctaw families came in pickups from out toward Soper, and the kids from the Black Baptist church on the north side came running down through the timber in their Sunday shoes. The fire department came out with ropes. The man from the radio station in Paris came. A Corps of Engineers man in a hard hat walked up and down saying the flat was not stable, which everybody could see. Bharat had seen the trucks going by on 70 and had called his cousins, and the young men from the motels stood together a little apart at the top of the bank, near the road, the way they stood everywhere.

Raju had never seen an elephant except on a poster. In India his grandfather's village had kept one at the temple, and his father had told him about it. He stood at the top of the bank with his hands in the pockets of his windbreaker and looked at her.

All along the bank the people were saying the same thing. They said it gently, mostly. Old men who had seen her raise the big top said it, shaking their heads. *Would you look at that. That's Rani. That's the old bull that pulled the Floyd show out of the mud in Fort Smith. I saw her do it. And look at her now. Just look at her now.*

The young men heard it, and did not say it. They stood at the top of the bank and talked among themselves in Gujarati, the way they did, about other things. The Desai brothers stood at opposite ends of the row. Bharat kept walking up to the road to look at his watch, because his father was meeting a man from the bank in Durant at five and had told him to be there and keep quiet. Mahesh said that in Baroda they would have had a crane out by now. Raju said nothing. He was looking past the elephant, across the flat and the highway, toward the east side of town, where you could not see the Starlite Motel from here, though he could see it anyway, the red, white and blue sign, the way he saw it every night from the door of the ice room.

The firemen got a rope around her neck and tied it off to the winch of a wrecker from the Texaco station, and the wrecker spun its wheels and dug itself into the bank and the rope sang and Rani did not move. They tried two wreckers. They tried thirty men on the rope, the young men from the motels among them, Dinesh at the very end with the rope burning through his hands. A veterinarian from Durant came and looked at her through binoculars and said she was tired and her heart was old and they had better do something quick, because she would not last the night standing in that cold, and if she lay down in it she would drown.

Rani stood in the mud with her eyes half shut and let them pull.

IV. The Drum

The west arm · that afternoon

Ray Bradley, who owned the show, was in a motel room in Joplin, Missouri, between a matinee and an evening performance, when the sheriff got through to him on the telephone. He listened a long while without saying anything. Then he said, *Put Dewey on.*

Somebody ran down to the bank and brought Dewey back up to the deputy's car, and he stood bent over with one hand on the roof and the radio handset to his ear.

Dewey, said Ray Bradley, a long way off and full of static. *You get her out of there.*

Dewey Haskins put the handset back. He stood for a moment by the car. Then he asked the deputy to drive him to the quarters, and they went off up the gravel road in a hurry, and the people on the bank looked at each other.

He was gone an hour. When the deputy's car came back down through the timber, Dewey got out of it in the spec.

He had kept it in a footlocker under his bed for nine years. A white silk turban with a glass jewel in front the size of a hen's egg and a plume of dyed ostrich feathers coming up out of it. A short jacket of purple satin crusted all over with gold braid and sequins, gone green at the edges. A red sash. Baggy white trousers tucked into red boots that curled up at

the toes. The ankus, the hook, with its handle wound in gold cord. In the car behind him, in the back seat, with its rim against the window, was the bass drum from the band's storage room at the quarters, BRADLEY BROS. painted around its head in circus letters, and a boy named Lonnie Walker from the north side who played in the high school band.

There was some laughing on the bank. Not much. A man near the young men from the motels said, *Lord, look at that. He's dressed up like one of yours,* and Mahesh looked at the man and looked away, and Raju, beside him, felt the heat come up into his face.

Dewey walked down the bank in the curled-up boots, slowly, on his bad hips, to the edge of the mud, and stood there where she could see him, with his chin up and the turban on his head and the ankus held up across his chest the way he had carried it at the head of the spec for thirty-one years. Lonnie Walker set the drum on its side in the grass behind him.

Hit it, son, said Dewey. *Hit it like they're opening the doors.*

Lonnie hit it. He hit it the way a band drummer does on the first beat of a march, all his arm behind the mallet, and the sound went out across the flat like a cannon and came back off the far shore.

Rani's eyes opened.

He hit it again, and again, the slow heavy four of the spec march, the one every circus band in America knows, and the drum boomed across the water. Up and down the bank people stopped talking. Rani's ears came out from her head, wide, wider, the way they had come out every night of her life when the doors of the big top opened and the band struck up and the light hit her. Her trunk came down off her head and went up into the air, and she trumpeted, one long blast that sent the herons up off every dead tree on the flat, and then she leaned her whole weight into the mud.

The mud made a sound nobody on that bank ever forgot. It was like a cow pulling her foot out of a creek bottom, but a thousand times over and so deep it shook in your stomach. She brought one foreleg up out of it, black to the shoulder, and set it down ahead, and sank, and brought the other one up. Dewey stood at the edge of the flat in his turban and did

not say a word and did not move. Lonnie Walker kept hitting the drum with the tears running down his face. She came on, one leg and then the other, with the grey muck pouring off her in sheets, and the rope still trailing from her neck, up out of the deep part and across the shallow part and up the bank. She walked past the fire department and past the wreckers and stood on the dry grass at the top of the bank in the evening sun, steaming, with the drum still going, and swung her trunk once, and laid the end of it on Dewey Haskins' turban.

Then the bank was nothing but noise. People were clapping and whistling and crying and slapping each other on the back, and the kids from the Baptist church were jumping up and down in their Sunday shoes, and an old man in a Choctaw Nation cap stood with his hat off. The young men from the motels stood at the top of the bank in a row and did not say anything at all.

V. The Other Mud

The Kiamichi Motor Court · that night

They went straight to the motel. It was not eleven yet and Kaka was still in the back, so they waited for him on the floor of the office on the bedspread from Room 14, in their muddy shoes, and when he came out in his cardigan and sat down behind the counter they all began to tell him at once.

He let them. Dinesh held up his hands to show the rope burns. Raju told about the drum and the turban and how the mud had sounded, and Bharat told about the man on the bank, and Mahesh, who did not usually say much on Sundays, told about her ears. *Kaka, you should have seen her ears. Like she heard her name.*

Kaka listened to all of it. When they ran out he sat for a while with his hands folded on the closed book. Out on the highway a truck went by, and the lights of the Starlite Motel came and went across the window.

So, he said. *The old bull got herself out of the mud.*

They waited.

That was only mud. Lake mud. It comes off with a hose. He looked at them, one at a time, the way he had looked at boys across a classroom in Kampala for thirty-four years. *And you boys. Every one of you has gone into a worse mud than that. Headfirst. Up to here.* He put the edge of his hand against his own throat. *Bharat, your father's note. Mahesh, how much you hate that desk in Paris, Texas. You two Desais, over four hundred dollars and a word your mother said at Diwali. Raju, that sign across the road. I have seen you looking at it. Every night you go out and stand by the ice machine and look at it. And I know that one with the beer in the ice room, I won't say who.*

Nobody said anything.

She had somebody to come with a drum. Nobody is coming for you with a drum. You have to be the drum. Get yourselves out.

Then he opened the book where his finger had been, and read to them, in the voice that the truck drivers took for English.

> *Let each man raise*
> *The Self by Soul, not trample down his Self,*
> *Since Soul that is Self's friend may grow Self's foe.*
>
> *— Bhagavad Gita 6:5*

He turned back two pages, and read again.

> *But, as often as the heart*
> *Breaks—wild and wavering—from control, so oft*
> *Let him re-curb it, let him rein it back*
> *To the soul's governance;*
>
> *— Bhagavad Gita 6:26*

He closed the book.

The young men sat on the bedspread from Room 14 with their backs against the soda machine. None of them could have told you afterward what happened to him then, and most of them never tried. Dinesh said once, years later, at his own daughter's wedding, that it was like the sound of that mud letting go, only on the inside, and without any sound. They sat there a long time. Nobody drank the tea. When the first trucker

came in off the turnpike at a quarter to twelve, Kaka stood up and handed him a key and said *Good night, sir,* and the young men got up off the floor and went out into the lot.

VI. Plates

Highway 70 · the summer of 1979

THE GASOLINE RAN SHORT THAT SUMMER, THE WAY THE truckers had said, and the highway went quiet, and the banks took back four motels between Durant and the Arkansas line. The Kiamichi Motor Court was not one of them. That was the summer the Desai brothers sat down together on the tailgate of a pickup behind the Antlers Motor Inn and settled their four hundred dollars in ten minutes. It was the summer Bharat drove to Dallas and told his father's lender the truth, and Mahesh signed up for a night course in Paris, Texas, and passed his engineering exam three years later, and the summer the beer stopped turning up in the ice room at the Kiamichi Motor Court and nobody ever said a word about it.

On the first hot morning in June Raju walked across Highway 70 to the Starlite Motel with a box of his aunt's sweets from the kitchen, the ones she made for Diwali, and knocked on the office door, and the man who owned the Starlite opened it in his undershirt and stood there looking at him a long time. The sign stayed up until the next spring, when the wind took it.

Kaka went on sitting at the front desk from eleven until seven. On Sunday nights the young men kept coming, more of them every year, until there was no room for them on the bedspread from Room 14 and Navin had to buy a rug.

And the morning after it happened, Raju drove out the Kiamichi road at sunrise on the way to buy ice, and stopped his uncle's car on the gravel by the Bradley Brothers fence, and got out.

Rani was standing in the pasture by the barn in the early light, with Dewey sitting on an overturned bucket beside her in his undershirt and his old work boots, drinking coffee out of a thermos lid. Nobody had

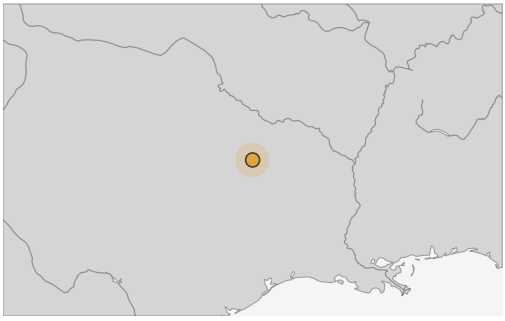
hosed her off yet. The mud of the lake had dried on her all night into a grey shell, and as the sun came up and warmed her she moved, a little, the way old animals move in the morning, and the mud cracked and came off her in plates, big curved grey plates the size of dinner platters, and fell into the grass around her feet, one, and then another, and another, until she stood there in the sun in her own skin.

Background

The verse

> *Be not thoughtless, watch your thoughts! Draw yourself out of the evil way, like an elephant sunk in mud.*
>
> Dhammapada 327, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Baddheraka is an elephant belonging to the king of Kosala, mighty in his youth. Worn out by age, he wades into a great lake one day, sticks fast in the mire and cannot get out, and the people who see him marvel that so strong an elephant has grown so weak. The king orders his elephant-trainer to free him. The trainer appears at the lakeside dressed as if for battle and has the battle-drum beaten. The old elephant's pride is roused, and he rises, walks out of the lake and stands on dry land. When monks report it, the Buddha tells them that the elephant has only pulled himself out of ordinary mud, while they have flung themselves into the far deeper mire of the defilements, and he urges them to strive with all their might to get out. Hearing the verse, those monks reach awakening. Read the full commentary story.



Hugo, Oklahoma

Hugo, Oklahoma, 1979

Circuses have wintered in Hugo, in the Choctaw Nation of southeastern Oklahoma, since the Al G. Kelly and Miller Brothers Circus moved there in 1941. As many as twenty shows have been based there at one time or another, and the town calls itself "Circus City, USA." Circus people lie buried in Showmen's Rest at Mount Olivet Cemetery. In circus language every elephant, male or female, is a "bull," and its keeper a bullman. A "mud show" was a circus that moved by wagon from town to town. Its wagons sank so often on wet lots that elephants were kept to pull them out. The U.S. Army Corps of Engineers finished damming the Kiamichi River for Hugo Lake, seven miles east of town, in 1974. A year later, in July 1975, two elephants escaped from a circus's off-season camp near Hugo into the woods.

In August 1972 Idi Amin gave the Asians of Uganda ninety days to leave the country, and each could take only a small sum of money with them (expulsion of Asians from Uganda). Most went to Britain, and about a thousand came to the United States. In the mid-1970s Gujarati families from India and East Africa began buying run-down roadside motels, which were cheap during the slump that followed the oil embargo. Investing about $40,000 in a business could qualify an immigrant for permanent residence. Insurers would not cover the motels and banks would not lend on them, so families financed one another and did all the work themselves, and some competitors answered with "American Owned" banners. Within a generation about half of the motels in the United States were owned by Indian Americans, most of them Gujarati. In 1979 the second oil crisis brought gasoline lines back to American highways.

After the story of the elephant Baddheraka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 327). The original. Scripture from the Bhagavad Gita, tr. Edwin Arnold, *The Song Celestial* (1885). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.7

The Firefinder

In solitude, be company for thyself.
— Montaigne, "Of Solitude"

This is the way I heard it, in the packers' bunkhouse at Ninemile.

I. The Seminar Room

The State University, Missoula · spring 1938

THE TROUBLE IN THE ENGLISH DEPARTMENT BEGAN WITH A saucer of pipe ash. Mr. Dace, who lectured on the modern poets and filled every room he lectured in, smoked through a seminar in the library's Seminar Room, under a card that said NO SMOKING BY ORDER OF THE LIBRARIAN, and left the saucer on the table when he went. Dr. Pell, who taught Old English and the history of the language and knew every rule of the library by heart, found it there in the morning. He asked Mr. Dace whether he had seen the card. Mr. Dace said he had not. Then it is nothing, said Dr. Pell, and Mr. Dace thought no more about it. But that week Dr. Pell said to his graduate students, as a joke, that the modern poets did not read. By March the department had two seminars where it had had one, the student paper had printed eleven letters, and the faculty wives sat at separate tables at the Faculty Club.

Edmund Coyle had been chairman for twenty-one years. He had built the department out of three men and a borrowed classroom, and both of the quarrelers had been hired by him. He was the son of a smelterman from Butte. As a young man he had worked a fire guard's summer in the Coeur d'Alenes and come out of the Big Burn of 1910 with his eyebrows gone. He asked the two of them three times to make it up. The third time he went to the Seminar Room himself, where a meeting of Mr. Dace's

side was going on, and said what he had to say, and a graduate student named Harlan Voss stood up at the back.

Professor Coyle, with respect, this is between the two of them, and you're not in it. Please let us be.

Coyle looked at him a while. Then he went back to his office and wrote out his resignation as chairman, and in June, when the term was over, he took the job the Forest Service had offered him every year since he was thirty: a summer on a lookout. It paid less than a teaching assistant. He drove out to Ninemile with a duffel bag and a box of books and asked for the highest one they had.

II. Sadie

Blue Point Lookout, Lolo National Forest · July to September

Blue Point was a fourteen-foot square of windows on top of a rock, an L-4 cab with a shingle roof and heavy shutters that propped out like awnings, built at Columbia Falls and carried up the mountain in pieces on mules. In the middle of the floor stood the Osborne firefinder, a round table two feet across with a map of the whole country under its glass and the 360 degrees cut into its rim, and a sighting ring that turned on it, so that a man who saw smoke could lay the hair of the sight across it and read the bearing to the ranger station down the telephone wire. Against the walls were a bed, a table, a wood stove and a stool with glass insulators on its four legs, for standing on in lightning.

What happened up there was told afterward by Ole Brekke, a Ninemile packer who had never read a book in his life and did not care who knew it, and by a forestry student on the next lookout to the west, who watched Blue Point every day through his glasses and wrote it down in his log.

Ole brought the first string up on the second of July: six mules with groceries, kerosene, the canvas water bags and the professor's books. Among them was a big brown molly named Sadie who had been at Ninemile since the depot opened and had never been anything but trouble on the line. The young mules crowded her on the trail and kicked at her in the corral and ate her hay. When Ole went to lead the string

down again, Sadie set her feet at the edge of the rocks below the lookout and would not go. He pulled. He swore at her in two languages. In the end he tied the others nose to tail and went down without her, and told the ranger she could stay up there and starve.

She did not starve. She kept house. The student on the next peak saw it, and Ole saw it himself when he came up with the second string. The spring was six hundred feet below the lookout, down a goat trail. Every morning Sadie went down to it with the two canvas water bags slung on her, and Coyle went with her and filled them, and she carried them back up, and after the first week, Ole swore, she went down by herself, and came up with the bags full, though nobody could say who had filled them. She dragged down deadfall to the woodpile by the stairs. When a bear came up through the beargrass in August she went at it with her ears flat back and her teeth showing and ran it off the mountain. On nights with lightning she stood under the stairs, close against the timbers, and did not move until it had passed.

Coyle sat in the windows and watched the country. He reported four smokes in July and nine in August. When there was nothing to report he read, and the book he read most was the old Cotton translation of Montaigne that he had bought secondhand in Butte when he was sixteen. Montaigne had been thirty-eight when he gave up his office and his city and climbed his own tower to sit among his books. Coyle was fifty-eight and had only the one book, and a mule.

> *Wives, children, and goods must be had, and especially health, by him that can get it; but we are not so to set our hearts upon them that our happiness must have its dependence upon them; we must reserve a backshop, wholly our own and entirely free, wherein to settle our true liberty, our principal solitude and retreat.*
>
> *— Montaigne, "Of Solitude"*

III. Miss Varner

The Blue Point trail · the last week of September

By the time the fall rains came and the fire season ended, the whole university had heard that the chairman of English was living on top of a mountain with a mule. The president wanted him back for the fall quarter. Mr. Lyle Danner, the lumberman, who had paid for the new wing of the library, wrote to say the same, and so did Mrs. Hattie Burke of the Board of Education, who had sent seven sons through the university and was the most formidable woman in western Montana. And the students came back in September from their summers in the mines at Butte and the harvest in the Palouse and the sawmills and the fire crews, and went to the department office, and asked Miss Varner to take them up. They had not heard him lecture since spring.

Edna Varner had been secretary of the English department for sixteen years. She typed his letters and his examinations and knew which drawer he kept his pipe cleaners in. She drove forty of them out to the trailhead on a Saturday in a borrowed school bus, and they climbed all morning, and at the saddle below the last pitch, where they could see the lookout, she stopped them.

Let me see him first, she said. *Three months of nobody, and then forty of you over the rocks at once. Wait here.*

She went on alone. Sadie saw her first. The mule came down the last of the trail at a run, with her ears pinned flat and her head low, and Edna Varner put one hand on the nearest rock and shut her eyes.

Sadie, said a voice from the catwalk. *Come back. Let her by. She keeps my office.*

The mule stopped. She came and stood in front of Miss Varner and put her nose against the rucksack on her back and took one of the straps in her teeth, as if she wanted to carry it. Miss Varner did not let her. She climbed the stairs with the rucksack on and went into the lookout. The firefinder stood in the middle of the floor with its glass shining, and his papers were on the table and his book was on the bed, and there was no other place to set anything down. She did not put the rucksack on the

firefinder. She put it on the floor. Through the window the mule watched her do it.

She sat down on the insulator stool. He was brown, and thinner, and his beard had come in grey.

You came alone?

There are forty of them at the saddle. I didn't know whether you'd want them.

Tell them to come up.

IV. The Catwalk

Blue Point · the same afternoon

They came up and stood around the catwalk in their boots and their summer sunburns, looking at the mule, who looked at them. There was not room for all of them inside. A girl from Great Falls said what most of them were thinking.

Professor, you must have had an awful summer. All alone up here, at your age. No one to cook. Nobody to talk to. Hauling your own water up that hill.

Sadie hauled my water, Coyle said. *Sadie did everything.*

He came out onto the catwalk and stood with his hands on the rail. Below them the whole country lay open, ridge behind ridge to the Bitterroots, blue and then bluer, with the first snow on the high ones and no smoke anywhere.

Montaigne had one friend in his life, he said. *When the man died he said the only reason he could ever give for loving him was, because it was he, because it was I. If you find a friend like that, keep him your whole life and be glad of him. If you don't, go by yourselves. You can do worse than by yourselves. Bias said the greatest part is the worse part, and he was a wise man, and he had sat on committees.*

Some of them laughed. Then he took the book out of his coat pocket and read them the place he had read most that summer.

> *'Tis not that a wise man may not live everywhere content, and be alone in the very crowd of a palace; but if it be left to his own choice, the schoolman will tell you that he should fly the very sight of the crowd: he will endure it if need be; but if it be referred to him, he will choose to be alone.*
>
> *— Montaigne, "Of Solitude"*

Then he took them into the lookout two and three at a time and showed them the firefinder. He turned the sighting ring for each of them and had them put an eye to the slot and look along the hair of the sight across the glass, at one ridge, sixty miles off, and then at a single tree on the ridge, and then he read them the bearing off the rim. Harlan Voss was one of them. He looked through the sight a long time.

Harlan Voss tried to say, years later, when he was chairman of an English department himself, in Oregon, what happened to the forty of them on the catwalk that afternoon. It was like the sight on the firefinder, he said. You stood in a glass room with the whole country around you, so much of it you could not look at it, and then somebody put your eye to a slot and a hair, and there was one tree, sixty miles away, as plain as your hand. And you knew exactly where you were standing, to the degree.

Then Miss Varner gave him the message. The president says come down. Mr. Danner says come down. Mrs. Burke says come down. The whole university wants you home.

Coyle looked out at the ridges a while longer. *All right,* he said. *Somebody will have to carry the books.*

V. The Hood

Blue Point · the first of October

Ole Brekke came up a week later with the string to close the lookout. He hauled down the stove and the bedding and nailed the shutters closed. Last of all he put the canvas hood over the firefinder, the way the manual said, and tied it, so the glass would not crack in the cold. When he came out the snow had started. Sadie was standing at the

HEAD OF THE TRAIL BY HERSELF, ALREADY HEADED DOWN, waiting for the others to fall in behind her.

Background

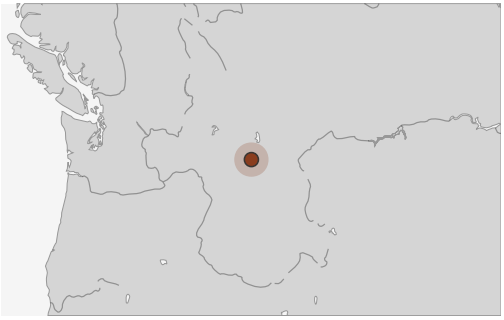
The verses

> *If a man find a prudent companion who walks with him, is wise, and lives soberly, he may walk with him, overcoming all dangers, happy, but considerate.*
>
> Dhammapada 328, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If a man find no prudent companion who walks with him, is wise, and lives soberly, let him walk alone, like a king who has left his conquered country behind,—like an elephant in the forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 329, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *It is better to live alone, there is no companionship with a fool; let a man walk alone, let him commit no sin, with few wishes, like an elephant in the forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 330, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

This commentary story continues the quarrel of the monks of Kosambī (told in this series as The Washing Cup). Having failed to reconcile them, the Buddha spends the rains alone in the Protected Forest, where a noble elephant, Pārileyyaka, serves him. Afterward the great lay followers Anāthapiṇḍika and Visākhā, and five hundred monks who have been living elsewhere, ask Ānanda to bring them to the Teacher. Ānanda leaves the monks outside and goes in alone; the elephant charges him with a stick until the Buddha calls it off, then offers to carry his bowl and robe. Ānanda declines, and he does not set his things on the stone slab where the Teacher sits. When the monks come in, they pity the Buddha for having had no one to serve him. He answers that the elephant did everything, speaks the three verses, and the five hundred become arahats. Read the full commentary story. The words standing in for the verses are from Montaigne's essays "Of Solitude" and "Of Friendship," in Charles Cotton's translation as edited by W. C. Hazlitt. By 1571 Montaigne had withdrawn from public life to the tower of his château, and he began the *Essays* there.



Lolo National Forest, Montana

Western Montana, 1938

After the Great Fire of 1910 burned about three million acres of Idaho and Montana, the Forest Service built fire lookouts on summits across the Northwest. The most common design, the L-4, was a gabled cab with heavy shutters, and more than a thousand were put up across the western states. The ones of the 1930s were made in Columbia Falls, Montana, and shipped in pieces small enough to pack in on animals. Inside stood the lookout's chief tool, the Osborne Fire Finder: a round, glass-topped table with a map under the glass and the 360 degrees etched in its rim. For lightning there was a stool standing on glass insulators.

In 1930 the Forest Service bought a ranch in the Ninemile valley northwest of Missoula and opened the Ninemile Remount Depot. For thirty-two years it bred mules to pack supplies to fire crews and backcountry lookouts, and at its height it kept over 1,500 animals and thirty-five packers. Pack strings still winter there.

After the story of a company of bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 328–330). The original. Quotations from Montaigne's *Essays*, translated by Charles Cotton, edited by William Carew Hazlitt (1877). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

23.8

The Added Dish

> *The superior man has three things in which he delights, and to be ruler over the empire is not one of them.*
> *— Mencius, Book VII, Part I, 20*

Ngoi hiang ngin gam gong, in the wooden house on the island.

I. The Wooden House

Angel Island, San Francisco Bay · June 1925

The men called the place the wooden house. It stood on the north side of the island above a cove, a long barracks of fir boards with bars on the windows and a fence around the yard, and that summer about two hundred of them slept in one room of it on iron bunks hung three high. The country they had come to lay across the water. They had called it Gold Mountain since before they could walk. From the windows on the water side a piece of it could be seen, a long line of bare hills that were brown all day, and for a quarter of an hour before the evening fog came through they were the color the name said.

Moy Sin-saang had the bottom bunk by the second post. He was forty-four years old, a schoolmaster from a village of the Moy name below Toisan city, and he had come in the middle of March on a teacher's paper to take the evening classes at a school on Stockton Street. For forty years and more a teacher had been one of the few kinds of Chinese the law let in. The new law of the summer before used the word differently, and nobody at the station could tell him whether a man who taught children their first thousand characters over a dry-goods store still counted. His file had gone to Washington. He had been in the wooden house fifteen weeks, longer than anyone but old Lew.

He was one of the few men in the room whose paper name was his own. Most of the others were somebody's son on paper, and had spent the crossing learning a village they had never slept in, how many steps went up to the door, which wall the rice bin stood against. The Sin-saang thought no worse of them. The law had been made so that hardly anyone could come in by the front, and they had families who had sold fields to send them. In the mornings he taught the boys, of whom there were always twenty or so between ten and sixteen. He sat them on the floor between the bunks with one brush and a board and a cup of water, since water dries off a board and the board can be written on again. In the afternoons he wrote letters for the men who could not. His own letters went to his father and mother, who were both living, in the house where he was born.

The room kept itself, after a fashion. Some years back the men had made an association, the Gee Gee Wui, which means that they would rule themselves, and which in English had given itself the name of the Liberty Association. It took a dollar or two from each new man and bought brushes with it, and a barber's kit, and the newspapers from the city. It told the new ones what to say and what never to say aloud where a watchman could hear. It spoke for the room when the rice was sour. It had officers, and the officers sat at the table nearest the kitchen door. When a cook's helper set down in front of them a dish nobody had asked for, and said *ga choi*, an added dish, there would be a folded paper somewhere in it for a man whose answers before the Board had not matched his father's.

And it had the dark room. This was a linen closet with a chair in it. A boy who stole, or fought, or left the tap running, was shut in there by the officers for half an hour to think. One who had taken fifty cents from under a pillow had sat there most of a week.

In the last week of June the papers from the city were full of Canton. On the twenty-third the foreign soldiers on Shameen had fired across the canal into a parade of students and workmen, and the dead were counted past fifty. Every man in the room had a cousin in Canton, or thought he might. On the thirtieth there was trouble in the dining hall. Nobody

agreed afterward what began it, only that it was not the food. Bowls went over. The watchmen in their green coats backed out through the doors, and then soldiers from the fort on the other side of the island came and stood along the wall with bayonets on their rifles while two hundred men were counted back up the stair, one, two, three, in bad Chinese.

That night old Lew, who had been chairman since the winter, put two boys of fourteen in the dark room for throwing the first bowls. Then he said he was tired, and that the room should choose somebody else in the morning. A good many men looked toward the bunk by the second post.

The Sin-saang lay awake. He had the bayonets in his mind, and the canal at Canton, and the two boys in the closet, to whom he had that morning taught the character for a person, two strokes leaning on each other. For twenty years he had set boys to copy what Mencius told the king of Liang.

> *Now among the shepherds of men throughout the empire, there is not one who does not find pleasure in killing men. If there were one who did not find pleasure in killing men, all the people in the empire would look towards him with outstretched necks.*
>
> *— Mencius, Book I, Part I, 6*

Tonight he put it to himself as a question. Could it be done at all? Could a room be kept, or a district, or a country, with no bayonet standing behind it and no closet, with nobody struck down and nobody set to strike, nobody made to grieve, and only by what was right? He went over it the way he went over a boy's composition, slowly, with the brush held back.

II. The Visitor

The same night

NOW THERE IS ONE WHO LISTENS FOR A THOUGHT OF THAT kind. The men of the wooden house told it this way afterward. He heard the schoolmaster asking whether a man might govern, and took it that the schoolmaster wished to. And he reckoned that a chairman has a great

DEAL TO SEE TO, AND THAT A MAN WITH A GREAT DEAL TO SEE to can be caught looking the other way.

The door was locked from outside, as it was every night, and the watchman had his chair in the hall. Nobody heard the bolt. A man was sitting on the edge of the Sin-saang's bunk. He wore a gray suit of American cut and a straw hat, like the interpreters who came over on the morning boat, and he had a gold chain across his vest and a good deal of gold in his mouth. He spoke low. Chin, in the bunk above, said afterward that he spoke pure Hoiping, the speech of Chin's own market town. Wong, across the aisle, said no, Toisan city, anybody could hear it. Every man who was awake heard the talk of the next lane over from his own mother's door.

Sin-saang, he said, *take the chair tomorrow. They will give it to you if you only look up when they look at you. Be the one the old book asks for. Keep this room with nobody in the closet and nobody's bowl empty and nobody sorry, by what is right and nothing else.*

The Sin-saang sat up. *What do you see in me, that you say this to me?*

What the room sees. In April you wrote six answers for the Lee boy on the paper off a cigarette, and the Board asked him those six, in that order, and no others. You wrote to the consul about the rice and the rice was changed. They say that what you set down comes out so. If you looked at those hills tonight and wrote that they were gold, they would be gold to the top by morning. He smiled, and the gold showed. *You need not trouble to. The added dish goes to the chairman's table. Every paper that comes onto this island would come through your hand, and every man's landing with it, and there are families in four counties who would sell the roof to buy one. Leave that part to me. I will do with it everything that money does. Lawyers in Washington. The watchmen. The inspector's clerk. A school on Stockton Street with your name cut over the door. So you will govern justly, and want for nothing while you do.*

The Sin-saang looked toward the water side, where at that hour there was nothing to see but the lamp at the end of the wharf.

They named that whole country Gold Mountain before any of us had seen it, he said. *If it were gold, every hill, and a second country of gold were set down*

on top of it, that would still not be enough for one man. Ask the men who own it whether they have enough. They built this house.

And a man who has once seen where his trouble comes from, and what it is tied to, how is he to lean that way again? When he knows the rope for a rope he works at the knot.

The men who told it said the visitor took his hand off the bunk rail then, as a man takes it off a stove.

I will say it to you once more, since you came so far, said the Sin-saang. *You and I have nothing to do with each other. These things are pleasant. A friend at the door when a man comes back up from the Board. This rice, on the days it is the rice there is. Something done rightly, to have by you on the morning they put you on the boat. And to have set all of it down, that most.* Then he said the rest as he had said it to boys for twenty years, not loudly, like a man hearing a lesson.

> *The superior man has three things in which he delights, and to be ruler over the empire is not one of them.*
>
> *That his father and mother are both alive, and that the condition of his brothers affords no cause for anxiety;—this is one delight.*
>
> *That, when looking up, he has no occasion for shame before Heaven, and, below, he has no occasion to blush before men;—this is a second delight.*
>
> *That he can get from the whole empire the most talented individuals, and teach and nourish them;—this is the third delight.*
>
> *The superior man has three things in which he delights, and to be ruler over the empire is not one of them.*
>
> *— Mencius, Book VII, Part I, 20*

He did not say that his father and mother were both living, or that in fifteen weeks he had told the Board nothing that was not so, or what he did with the boys in the mornings. The room knew those three things about him already.

The visitor stood up. He had the look of a man who comes to collect and is shown the receipt. He went down the aisle between the bunks, and

he was at the door, and then he was not in the room, and still nobody had heard the bolt. In three tiers of bunks not one man had been asleep. It is said they were not the only ones who listened. The walls of that house are cut all over with the verses of men who waited there before, and the ones who lay nearest them said the boards were quieter that night than wood is.

III. The Added Dish

July to December

In the morning the room chose a Hoiping man named Fong, who had been a shipping clerk in Hong Kong and had some English, and he did well enough. The two boys came out of the closet in time for breakfast. Old Lew was landed in August, after seventeen months, and wept on the stair, and left the Sin-saang his blanket.

The Sin-saang kept his board and his cup of water. He taught the character for a person to every new boy who came up from the boat. He wrote the letters. When the room looked at him, on the days when there was something to decide, he looked up and said what he thought and went back to what he was doing. Each evening he watched the hills go gold for their quarter hour, with the interest of a man looking into the window of a shop where he needs nothing, and then the fog took them.

In December the judges in the city ruled on another schoolmaster's paper, the same kind as his. Under the new law, they said, a teacher meant a professor of a college or an academy, a seminary or a university, and a certificate that said teacher and no more would not do. His own order came the week after. He would go back on the next boat.

On his last evening the cook's helper came out of the kitchen with a dish, walked past the officers' table, and set it down in front of the Sin-saang where he sat among the boys. *Ga choi,* he said. Fong and the others watched it go by. It was a fish steamed whole with ginger, which that kitchen could do well, having been built with steam kettles and not one wok. The Sin-saang turned it over with his chopsticks from head to tail,

as every man in the hall had seen an added dish turned over. There was nothing in it but the fish.

He served the boys first, and gave the cheek to the smallest.

Background

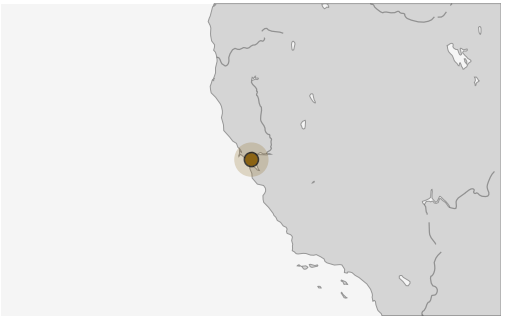
The verses

> *If an occasion arises, friends are pleasant; enjoyment is pleasant, whatever be the cause; a good work is pleasant in the hour of death; the giving up of all grief is pleasant.*
>
> Dhammapada 331, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Pleasant in the world is the state of a mother, pleasant the state of a father, pleasant the state of a Samana, pleasant the state of a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 332, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Pleasant is virtue lasting to old age, pleasant is a faith firmly rooted; pleasant is attainment of intelligence, pleasant is avoiding of sins.*
>
> Dhammapada 333, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the Buddha is living in a forest hut in the Himalaya country at a time when kings oppress the people they rule, and he asks himself whether sovereignty could be exercised without killing or conquest or sorrow, with justice. Māra, the tempter, overhears the thought and takes it for ambition. He urges the Buddha to rule: a man of his powers could turn the Himalaya to gold, and Māra will see to everything wealth can do. The Buddha answers that a mountain of gold twice over would not be enough for one person, tells Māra the two of them have nothing in common, and speaks these verses on what is truly pleasant. Many gods who were listening, the story adds, understood. Read the full commentary story, or about Māra.



Angel Island, San Francisco Bay, California

Angel Island, 1925

The Angel Island Immigration Station opened in 1910 to enforce the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, which barred Chinese laborers and let in only a few exempt classes, among them merchants, students and teachers. Most others who came claimed to be the children of citizens, many of them as "paper sons," and were questioned before a Board of Special Inquiry on the smallest details of a village and a family. By the mid-1920s the wait for a hearing ran two or three weeks, but a man on appeal could be held as long as two years. The Immigration Act of 1924 narrowed the exempt classes further. On December 7, 1925, in *Jeu Jo Wan v. Nagle*, the federal appeals court in San Francisco upheld the exclusion of a Chinese teacher who held the old certificate, ruling that the new act limited teachers to "professors of colleges, academies, seminaries, or universities." Moy Sin-saang is invented; the ruling is not. California had been Gold Mountain in Cantonese since the Gold Rush.

The detained men's own society, the Zizhihui or Self-governing Association (in the Toisan speech of most detainees, Gee Gee Wui), called itself in English the Angel Island Liberty Association. The historian Him Mark Lai dated it to 1922; the Angel Island foundation gives 1918. Lai's essays describe its officers, chosen from the men held longest and "at times respected intellectuals," its dues, books and classes for the children, and the coaching notes that Chinese kitchen workers smuggled to the officers' table under the words *ga choi*. Former detainees also remembered the "dark room," a linen closet where the association shut up boys who stole or fought. Lai records two dining-hall disturbances in 1925, one on June 30 that brought soldiers with fixed bayonets from Fort McDowell, and notes that the food was apparently not the cause. A week earlier, on June 23, British and French troops had fired on a demonstration in Canton, the Shameen Incident. The poems the detainees cut into the barracks walls can still be read there. The schoolmaster's two passages are from James Legge's translation of Mencius.

After the story of Māra from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 331–333). The original. Scripture from the Works of Mencius, translated by James Legge (1861). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 24

Thirst

24.1

The Yellow Cod

> *Out of the same mouth proceedeth blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not so to be.*
> *— James 3:10*

As I was credibly informed, at Gull Cove.

I. Two Callings

Ipswich, in the Massachusetts Bay · 1641

Hannah Golding brought her two sons over from Essex with her daughter Thankful at the breast, and buried her husband at sea the second week out. She settled at Ipswich and kept a little shop of pins and thread and Spanish salt, and she raised the boys hard, on the catechism and on cornmeal, because those were what there was.

When they were grown, Samuel at twenty and Elnathan at seventeen, the two of them went together to old Mr. Pell, who had been their minister since the ship, and asked him what was required of a man.

Mr. Pell had no teeth left and very little patience, and he answered them as if they had asked the way to Rowley.

Two things. Learning, and godliness. A man may have the first without the second and be damned. A man may have the second without the first, and be saved, and know very little about it.

Samuel said he would see to his soul. He was not quick at books and knew it. He took a grant of land up the Merrimack, at the edge of the settled country, where the woods came down to the river, and went up there with an axe and a Bible and a cow, and lived alone, and prayed. He did that for five years, and at the end of it something had been settled in

him that never came unsettled again, though he could not have told you in words what it was, and never tried.

Elnathan said he was young yet. When he was old, he would see to his soul. He went to the college at Cambridge, where he learned Latin and Greek and Hebrew and the logic of Ramus, and could say the whole Epistle to the Romans from memory, in two languages, and argue either side of any question put to him, and win.

II. Empty Hands

Cranfield, on the Merrimack · 1650–1672

The church at Cranfield called him at twenty-six, and in five years he had made it the most talked-of pulpit north of Boston. People rode in from three towns on a Sabbath to hear him. He preached two hours by the glass and turned the glass over and went on, and nobody slept. He had a voice like a bell and a face that warmed when he spoke of the mercy of God, and when he preached on the glory of Christ, old men wept who had not wept since England. The town raised his salary three times. They built him a house with a parlor and gave him a pew for his mother and sister at the front, under the pulpit, and every November the whole town turned out with ox-sleds to bring in the minister's wood, forty cords of it, more than any minister in the Bay was given.

He began to notice how much he was given, and to want more, and to know that what he knew was the reason. And he began, slowly, then all at once, to find that the other ministers of the Bay did not know very much.

At the meetings of the ministers he took the other side of every question, to see if he could carry it, and he could. When the synod was called on the baptism of the children of half-members, he spoke against it until it passed and for it after, and men who had voted with him found him voting against them. He said a thing was sound doctrine that he had called rotten the year before. He said a man was a heretic whom he had praised. When the elder ministers took him aside and opened the Scriptures to him and said, *Brother Golding, you should not speak so,* he looked at them and laughed.

What do you know? he said. *You have empty hands. You have no Hebrew. You could not construe a verse of Isaiah if your salvation hung on it.*

They sent for his brother.

Samuel came down out of the woods in his patched coat and stood in the minister's parlor at Cranfield, among the books, and talked to him alone. *Elnathan, if you are a minister of Christ, then the life of it is in how you live. You have the doctrine. Do not throw away the life for the doctrine.* Elnathan heard him out and showed him to the door.

Samuel came again in the spring with two of the brethren from the church, as the Scripture says to do, and the three of them told him the same thing. Elnathan did not show them to the door. He kept them standing in the parlor for an hour while he proved them wrong out of the Greek.

The third time, Samuel came alone and did not take his hat off.

Well, brother, he said. *Have it your way. You will be a byword.*

He walked home up the river, and after that the ministers of the Bay stopped asking Mr. Golding to their meetings, and stopped going to his. He gathered other men around him who were like him, and they quarreled among themselves when there was nobody else to quarrel with. Twice he left Cranfield for a richer church and twice came back when the richer church had had enough of him, so that the people said he went from pulpit to pulpit like a squirrel in a nut tree.

There was a day before the Lord's Supper in the spring of 1669 when he stood up before the church at Cranfield to ask, as the minister does, whether any brother had a matter to bring before the church, any offense not yet confessed, any quarrel not yet healed, before they came to the table. The brethren sat in their pews and looked at the floor. They had decided among themselves what use it was to answer him, which was none. Nobody spoke. The silence went on until a dog barked outside.

Brethren, said Mr. Golding, *then there is no church here, and no discipline, and no ordinances. What does it matter whether you hear me or not?* And he came down out of the pulpit and walked out of the meetinghouse with the Supper untouched on the table, and the church at Cranfield did not take the Lord's Supper again for four years.

His mother and his sister went with him. They had sat under him every Sabbath for twenty years, and had learned from him how to speak of the brethren, and spoke so. Thankful Golding said in the street that the deacons' wives could not read. Hannah said worse.

Samuel died at his place up the river in the winter of 1670, in his chair by the fire, with his Bible shut on his knee. The neighbor who found him said he looked like a man who had just been told good news. Elnathan died two years after, at forty-eight, of a cancer in the mouth. Those who sat with him at the end said that for the last month nobody could stay in the room with him, for the smell of it, and that his mother and sister did, and that he cursed the three of them together until his voice gave out. Hannah and Thankful followed him within the decade, and that was the end of the Goldings of Cranfield.

III. Seven

The woods above the Merrimack · October 1666

Four years before Samuel died, seven men came to his door in the night.

They were runaways, most of them, bound servants who had broken their indentures, and one was a sailor off a Bristol ship, and their captain was a big red-headed man named Harnett who had run from a farm at Andover. All that summer they had lived in the woods and come out at night to rob the farms along the river, cows and pigs and corn and once a whole cellar of cider, and in September they had broken into a house at Haverhill and taken the money out of a chest, and the man of the house had come at them with a fowling piece and been knocked down and lay a week before he could speak. Now the townsmen were out after them, forty men with guns and dogs, and the seven came through the dark with the dogs behind them and saw Samuel's light.

They pushed in at the door. Samuel was sitting at the table. He did not get up.

Hide us, said Harnett. *For the love of God, Goodman, be our refuge.*

Samuel looked at them a long time. There was a great deal of mud on them, and blood on one.

There is no refuge for you in this house, he said. *There is no refuge for you anywhere but the commandments. Will you keep them? All of you? Every one of them, from tonight?*

They said they would. Perhaps they thought he was going to hide them if they said so. He took the Bible down and read them the commandments from the twentieth of Exodus, every one, slowly, and when he had read each one he made each man say it back to him. Then he shut the book.

Now you have promised, he said. *Do not break one of them, not to save your lives. Not one. Not by a lie.*

The townsmen came at first light and stood around the cabin in the frost with their guns. They called out to know who was inside. Harnett might have said nobody but the old man and his cow. He went to the door and opened it and said there were seven of them, and that they had robbed the farms and the house at Haverhill, and that they would not fight. The seven came out into the yard with their hands open.

The townsmen had been out three nights in the cold, and the man at Haverhill was still lying in his bed not knowing his own wife, and nobody was in a mind to wait for the court at Boston. Somebody fired. Then they all fired. Samuel stood in his doorway and shouted at them to stop until his voice broke, and when it was over he went down into the yard among the seven and knelt there. He buried them himself on the slope behind his cabin, in a row, under the pines, and cut seven stakes for them, and did not know the names of six.

• • •

That same night, fifty miles away at Gull Cove, where the fishing families had their stages and their flakes on the rocks below Cape Ann, a boy was born to Ebenezer Tuck, who owned two shallops and was the first man in the place. By morning Ebenezer had heard from the midwife that she had been run off her feet. He went from house to house down the shore and

counted, and there were seven boys born in the Cove between dark and daylight, and not one girl.

Well, he said. *These will be my Ben's crew.* And he sent every one of the seven houses a quintal of dry fish and a bushel of meal, and said he would stand to it every year until they were grown.

The old women of the Cove said, when they heard about the seven men in the woods, that seven had gone out that night and seven come in on the tide. Nobody at Gull Cove took that for doctrine. They said it anyway.

IV. The First Fare

Gull Cove · September 1686

THE SEVEN GREW UP TOGETHER ON THE ROCKS AND IN THE boats. They learned to split and salt fish before they could write their names, and some of them never did learn that, and by twelve they were going out with their fathers to the ledges off Cape Ann, and by sixteen to the Isles of Shoals, and by eighteen down east to Cape Sable for the spring fare. Ben Tuck was the best of them in a boat and the first of them in everything else, and the other six followed him as if it had been settled before they were born, which in a sense it had.

Gull Cove was not a godly place. It had a meetinghouse, and a minister, and a tithingman with a long staff to wake sleepers. But the men were at sea half the Sabbaths of the year and drunk a fair part of the rest, and when they were in church they sat in the back and smelled of fish. Not one fisherman in ten was in full communion. The ministers of the Bay spoke of Gull Cove as they spoke of the Isles of Shoals, with a sigh.

In the summer of 1686, when the seven were twenty, Ebenezer Tuck gave them his old shallop, and they caulked her and rigged her and went out on their own for the first time. It was not a real fare. They had a seine, and they meant to haul for bait in the Cove at the turn of the tide, and they did, at first light, all seven of them on the lines with their feet in the cold water.

The seine came in heavy. When they got the bunt of it up on the stones, there were herring in it, and a skate, and in the middle of the herring, thrashing so the whole net shook, a cod as long as a man's leg.

It was yellow. Every man of them had seen ten thousand cod, and this one was gold, from the barbel on its chin to the end of its tail, with its spots showing through like the pattern in a damask cloth. The sun came up over the point while they stood looking at it, and it shone.

The whole Cove came down to see it. The women came with their sleeves wet from the wash, and the old men from the flakes, and the boys, and the minister's servant. *The first time those seven put out a net,* they said, *and look what they bring in.* Somebody said a fish like that was fit for the King. Somebody said Mr. Thorne at Salem sent curiosities to the gentlemen of the Royal Society at London, a two-headed calf once and a stone with a fern in it, and was paid for them, and would pay for this. So they put the cod in a hogshead of seawater on Ebenezer's cart and took it to Salem.

The Worshipful Mr. Joseph Thorne, magistrate, came out on his steps and looked into the hogshead for a long time.

What is it? he said.

A cod, your worship, said Ben Tuck.

Mr. Thorne had sent a great many curious things to London and believed he knew what was natural. He could see that this was not. He was not a superstitious man, but he was a careful one.

Your minister at the Cove, he said. *Mr. Hollings. He was at the college. He will know why it is gold.* And he called for his horse, and rode back to Gull Cove behind the cart.

V. The Fish Speaks

The meetinghouse at Gull Cove

Mr. Amos Hollings was twenty-eight years old. His father had fished out of Marblehead and drowned off Cape Sable, and the church at Marblehead had paid for the boy to go to the college because he could read Latin at nine and there was nothing else to be done with

HIM. HE HAD BEEN CALLED TO GULL COVE BECAUSE NO ONE else would come. He was a plain, quiet young man with chapped hands, who preached for one hour exactly, and who could be found most days in his garden behind the parsonage on his knees, digging quitch grass out of his bean rows with a knife.

They carried the hogshead into the meetinghouse because there was nowhere else to put it, and set it down before the pulpit. Half the Cove crowded in after it, and stood in the pews and on the benches.

Mr. Hollings looked into the water. The cod hung there, gold, turning slowly. Then it opened its mouth.

Every person who was in the meetinghouse that morning said the same thing about it for the rest of their lives, and some of them lived to be very old. They were fishing people, who lived in the smell of fish and never noticed it. This they noticed. It was the smell of a sickroom where somebody has lain a long time dying, and of a privy in August, and of something under that which had no name, and it filled the meetinghouse in a breath, and went out the door, and down the shore, so that women on the flakes a quarter of a mile away put their aprons over their faces. Mr. Thorne put his sleeve to his nose and turned grey.

Mr. Hollings, he said through the sleeve. *How came this fish to be gold? And how came its breath to stink so?*

Mr. Hollings did not answer him. He knelt by the hogshead, as he knelt in his bean rows, and put his face close to the water, closer than anybody else would have stood.

I will let him answer for himself, he said. And then, to the fish: *Are you Elnathan Golding, that was minister at Cranfield?*

The cod's mouth moved. Some of those who were there said afterward that they heard nothing but the water slopping, and some said it was a voice like a bell, and some said it was a voice like a man with his mouth full of earth. But everyone heard the answers, and the answers were the same in every telling.

I am.

Where have you come from?

From hell.

Where is your brother Samuel?
With God.
Where is your mother Hannah?
In hell.
Where is your sister Thankful?
In hell.
And where are you going now?
To hell.

And the yellow cod turned in the water, and drove itself headfirst against the side of the hogshead, once, so hard that the staves cracked and the water ran out across the meetinghouse floor, and it lay in the wet on the boards and was dead.

Nobody in the meetinghouse moved. The hair stood up on the arms of grown men. Ben Tuck said afterward that he looked down and saw the water running between his feet and could not remember what it was.

Mr. Hollings stayed on his knees by the dead fish. When he spoke he did not go up into the pulpit. He spoke from the floor, in the wet, as if he were talking to one person.

He was gold because for twenty years he preached Christ, and spoke the praises of God, and men wept to hear him. That was true and it stayed true. And his breath was what it is because with the same mouth he cursed the brethren, and called them empty hands, and broke a church in pieces because it would not answer him.

> *Out of the same mouth proceedeth blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not so to be. Doth a fountain send forth at the same place sweet water and bitter?*
>
> *— James 3:10–11*

VI. Quitch Grass

The Sabbath following

They buried the cod in the sand above the tide line beyond the point, deep, and the smell did not leave the meetinghouse for a

MONTH. THEY WASHED THE FLOOR WITH LYE AND WHITE-washed the walls and kept the doors open in the rain, and still on the Sabbath you could catch it, under the smell of wet wool, and people looked at each other.

Mr. Hollings preached that Sabbath to the fullest meetinghouse Gull Cove had ever had. Men stood in the doorways. The seven sat together in the back, in their good shirts, all in a row.

He did not preach on hell. Everyone had expected him to, and he did not. He preached on what the Scripture says a church must do with a scorner, which is to put him out, for the sake of the others and his own, and to have no more to do with him until he mends.

> *Cast out the scorner, and contention shall go out; yea, strife and reproach shall cease.*
>
> *— Proverbs 22:10*

And then he talked about his bean rows.

He said that every man in that meetinghouse knew quitch grass, because every man there had a wife with a garden. He said that you could cut it off at the top every morning of your life and it would be back by evening. He said that after a rain it came up twice as thick, and that a man who only ever cut the tops of it would end with a garden of nothing else. He said that the only way was to get down on your knees and follow the root under the earth with your fingers, all the white length of it, and pull it out whole, and that if you broke it and left one joint in the ground it would come again.

He said that Elnathan Golding had started with a garden as good as any in the Bay. He had wanted a little more, and then a little more after that, a bigger salary and more wood, a bigger church, a bigger name. He had gone from pulpit to pulpit like a squirrel after nuts, and every time it rained the wanting came up thicker, and choked everything else that was growing there, until there was nothing left in him but the wanting and the mouth.

> *And these are they which are sown among thorns; such as hear the word, And the cares of this world, and the deceitfulness of riches, and the lusts of other things entering in, choke the word, and it becometh unfruitful.*
>
> *— Mark 4:18–19*

He said that every person in that meetinghouse had the same root in them. He said it was in him, a fisherman's son who had wanted his whole life to be a Cambridge man and be looked at. He said he went into his garden every morning and got down on his knees for that reason as much as for the beans.

> *Looking diligently lest any man fail of the grace of God; lest any root of bitterness springing up trouble you, and thereby many be defiled.*
>
> *— Hebrews 12:15*

Then he said that he wished every soul in Gull Cove good, and sat down, and the people sang the psalm, lined out by the deacon a line at a time the way they did, and went home.

• • •

The next month the seven came to the parsonage together and asked to be taken into the church.

It was not a small thing at Gull Cove. A man who would come into full communion had to stand up before the whole congregation and tell, in his own words, how God had dealt with his soul, and be questioned on it, and fishermen as a rule would sooner have gone over the side in February. Mr. Hollings examined each of them in his study, one at a time, for an afternoon. Then on a Sabbath in November they stood up one after another in the meetinghouse, Ben Tuck first, and gave their relations. Some were long and some were very short. One of them, a boy named Caleb Pitman who could not read, said only that he had stood in the water on the meetinghouse floor and understood that he had been wanting

things his whole life, and that he would like to stop, and sat down, and the church voted him in with the rest.

All seven of them took the Supper together that winter, in a row, with their hands still raw from the salt. They fished together for thirty years after that, in the same boat and then in a ketch of their own, and it was said of them at Gull Cove that they never cheated a merchant on the weight of a quintal, and never quarreled over a share, and never in thirty years cursed a man, not even the Salem merchants, not even in February off Cape Sable with the ice on the shrouds.

Mr. Hollings watched them go out one morning that first winter from the parsonage window, where he stood with a cup of cider and dirt still on his knees. The seven of them were rowing out of the Cove in the flat calm before sunrise, pulling together. Every time the oars came up out of the sea the water ran off the blades in bright drops, and fell back, and nothing of it stayed on the wood.

Background

The verses

> *The thirst of a thoughtless man grows like a creeper; he runs from life to life, like a monkey seeking fruit in the forest.*
>
> Dhammapada 334, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Whomsoever this fierce thirst overcomes, full of poison, in this world, his sufferings increase like the abounding Birana grass.*
>
> Dhammapada 335, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who overcomes this fierce thirst, difficult to be conquered in this world, sufferings fall off from him, like water-drops from a lotus leaf.*
>
> Dhammapada 336, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *This salutary word I tell you, 'Do ye, as many as are here assembled, dig up the root of thirst, as he who wants the sweet-scented Usira root must dig up the Birana grass, that Mara (the tempter) may not crush you again and again, as the stream crushes the reeds.'*
>
> Dhammapada 337, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two brothers become monks in the time of an earlier Buddha, Kassapa. The elder, Sodhana, takes up meditation and reaches awakening. The younger, Kapila, takes up study, becomes famous and rich, and grows so proud that he calls right wrong and wrong right and mocks the other monks as "empty-fists." His brother admonishes him and gives him up. When no one will answer him at the recitation of the monastic rule, Kapila declares there is no Dhamma and no discipline, and walks out. His mother and sister follow his example, and all three go to hell. In the same age five hundred bandits take the precepts from a forest monk and keep them even when they are killed. Ages later they are reborn on one day as the sons of five hundred fishermen, and on their first outing they net a golden fish with breath that fouls the whole monastery. The king brings it to the Buddha, who has the fish name its brother, its mother, its sister and its fate. The fish dies, the Buddha teaches on craving, and the fishermen's sons become monks. Read the full commentary story.

Gull Cove, Massachusetts Bay

Massachusetts Bay, 1640s–1680s

Puritan Massachusetts gave full church membership, with the right to take the Lord's Supper and vote in church affairs, only to those who could give a public account of their conversion. The Half-Way Covenant, endorsed by a synod in 1662, let the baptized but unconverted children of members bring their own children to baptism. It set off a pamphlet war among the ministers and split congregations. In Boston, members who left First Church in 1667 founded the Third Church, and the two churches did not share communion for fourteen years. Ministers trained at Harvard College read the Scriptures in Latin, Greek and Hebrew, and towns paid them in money, provisions and firewood. In 1684 Increase Mather published *An Essay for the Recording of Illustrious Providences*, a collection of sea deliverances, apparitions and other wonders gathered from ministers and witnesses across New England.

Along the North Shore, fishing towns like Marblehead lived on cod. Small boats worked the near ledges and, farther off, the grounds toward the Isles of Shoals and Nova Scotia, and the catch was split, salted and dried on wooden flakes along the

shore, then shipped by the quintal from Salem and Boston to Europe and the West Indies. Marblehead was never firmly under Puritan control, and when its church was formally gathered in 1684 it had only fifteen men and thirty-nine women in full membership. Gull Cove, Cranfield and every person in this story are invented.

After the story of Kapilamaccha from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 334–337). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24.2

The Gilt

> *This is repeated over and over, and unless this person can experience an entire psychic change there is very little hope of his recovery.*
> *— "The Doctor's Opinion," Alcoholics Anonymous (1939)*

The way it's told in the rooms, in Freeborn County.

I. The Hog House

Freeborn County, Minnesota · August 1965

Arnold Enger had the Watkins route in the south half of Freeborn County for thirty-one years. For the house he carried vanilla and black pepper and the red liniment. For the barn he carried stock dip and fly spray and a hog mineral, and so at every place he went to the barn as well as to the kitchen door. That summer he had a boy riding along to carry the case, a nephew of his wife's named Dale, who was fourteen.

On a morning in August they pulled into Tollef Sande's yard north of Hayward and nobody came out. The Sandes had gone to a funeral in Blue Earth. Arnold walked back to the hog house to leave a pail of mineral on account.

There was a radio going in there. Tollef kept one on a nail over the feed alley, tuned to WCCO, because he held that a gilt farrowed easier with a voice in the building. That was the summer the Twins were in first place, and no barn radio in southern Minnesota got shut off at night.

In the end pen were six Chester White gilts, bred for September, on straw that had been clean on Sunday. Five of them were up at the trough. The sixth was standing over a woman.

She was a young woman in what had been a yellow dress. She lay on her side in the wet corner where the gilts dunged, with one shoe gone and chaff in her hair. She was alive, because her hand moved. There was a Buick nose-down in the ditch a quarter mile up the road. Dale had seen it from the truck and not known what to say. She had come across a bean field in the dark toward the only light there was, which was the bulb over Tollef Sande's feed alley, and the only voice, which was the ball game.

The gilt stood with her front feet square and looked down at the woman. A hog's mouth turns up at the corners to begin with. This was not that, and Arnold Enger, who had looked at hogs all his life, said so until he died. The gilt was smiling. The sun came in low through the east door and lay along her wet snout and the row of her small teeth.

What are you grinning at? Arnold said to the pig.

The woman opened her eyes. She saw the gilt's face over her, close, with the light on it, and she looked at it for some time. Then she got up on her hands and knees, climbed the gate, and walked out past the man and the boy in her one shoe, toward the road. She did not say a word to them.

Who's that? said Dale.

That is the Hovey girl, Arnold said.

II. What the Gilt Knew

Hegre and Albert Lea · 1938 to 1965

In the rooms they tell it that the gilt knew what Arnold knew and the rest besides. This is what there was to know.

Glenna Hovey was born in her grandfather's house in Hegre, a town of two hundred then, and the grandfather lost the house. Her folks rented forty acres next to Hegre Lutheran. From the time she was six the hens were her job, and the hens liked the south wall of the church, where the ground was warm. On Tuesdays and Thursdays the confirmation class recited with the windows open. She stood under the sill with a pan of oyster shell and the hens around her feet. She heard twenty voices say a thing together and then ask together, *What does this mean?* and then say

what it meant. She could not have told you a word of it afterward. But the sound of it went into her, and they say it never came out.

That life ended overnight, the way it does for a hen when the hawk comes. The landlord's son came home from the service wanting the place, and the Hoveys were out by the first of March, which is the day tenants move in that country.

Her father got on at a creamery in Albert Lea. At eighteen she was Dairy Princess of Freeborn County. That was 1956. There was a white dress and a sash, and a rhinestone crown the dairy association kept in a hatbox from one year to the next. She rode a hay wagon in the fair parade and handed down half-pints of milk.

On the Saturday of the fair, in that dress, she went into the privy behind the cattle barn. The town had sewer, but there was still a two-holer back there for the stockmen. It was ninety degrees. She looked down, which nobody does, and the lime below was alive, white on white, turning over. Anyone else would have come out gagging. She stood where she was. They say she saw those maggots as plainly as you see your own hand, and went on seeing them, and that everything else in her went quiet. The parade marshal's wife found her twenty minutes later behind the barn with the crown in her hand and a look on her face like a lamp turned low.

It lasted five years. She could not explain it and did not try. She went to the teachers college at Mankato and taught the lower grades in a country school near Alden, and all that time nothing stuck to her. She did not want anything. People remembered her from those years as the calmest girl they ever knew, and some of them had found it hard to be around.

It was not hers to keep. Nothing had been done about what lay underneath it. In 1961 she married Dick Wendland, whose father had the International Harvester dealership and a house on Fountain Lake with a boathouse. There were highballs on the dock at five o'clock. The quiet went out of her the first summer, and what came up in its place came up thirsty. She was in that house fourteen months.

After that she was in the straw. They say the gilt saw the hen yard and the crown and the five white years and the boathouse, right down to the yellow dress. She saw the road going on from there too, and that was why

she smiled. There was no meanness in it. It was the smile you give a thing you know all the way through.

A gilt cannot say what she knows. If that one could have, it would have come out close to what a doctor in New York had written, the year after Glenna Hovey was born, for the front of a book.

> *After they have succumbed to the desire again, as so many do, and the phenomenon of craving develops, they pass through the well-known stages of a spree, emerging remorseful, with a firm resolution not to drink again. This is repeated over and over, and unless this person can experience an entire psychic change there is very little hope of his recovery.*
>
> *— "The Doctor's Opinion," Alcoholics Anonymous (1939)*

III. Geographics

Minnesota · 1965 to 1978

In the rooms they call it a geographic when you move somewhere to get away from it. She did seven.

An aunt took her in at Golden Valley. There was a spare room with a gold chenille spread, and she was kept like company, and she went four months without. Then it was Rochester, where she made beds in a hotel full of people who had come from all over the world to be cured, and she lasted until Christmas.

Then Duluth. She kept house for a man who traded horses, out toward Hermantown. He set wire snares for rabbits along his fence. One morning she found a snowshoe hare alive in one. It had run all night at the end of the wire, round the stake, and beaten a ring in the snow as hard and smooth as a dinner plate. She looked at the ring longer than she looked at the hare.

Then Two Harbors, with a wheelsman off an ore boat who was gone nine months of the year and whose house was in hearing of the docks. Then St. Paul, where a retired judge on Summit Avenue had senators to dinner. She poured for them and did not spill.

Between each of these and the next she was dry a while and sure of herself. The trouble was that it ran everywhere. There was not a town on the map without a place to get it across from the grain elevator. Wherever she set her suitcase down, it had got there ahead of her.

The sixth was home. Her mother was dead, and her father had a little house in Hegre again. By the back steps was a box elder he had cut down the year she was Princess, because it dropped bugs in the cistern. It had come up from the stump every spring since. Every May he went at the shoots with a corn knife, and every May there were more of them. By then he was seventy and it was a thicket.

You'd have to get the root, he said each year, and cut it off at the ground.

Hegre was going. The school had gone to Alden in the consolidation, the creamery was shut, and the church held service every other Sunday. In 1976 her father gave up the house and went into the Lutheran home in Albert Lea. She took a room nearby and visited.

Bud Lindahl found her there. He was an assistant commissioner of agriculture, down from St. Paul on some errand about the county fair, and he had stopped in to see an uncle across the hall. He stood five feet four in his shoes and was the most cheerful man in the Department. He married her in June of 1978 with three hundred at the dinner, and took her to a house in Edina with a lawn that ran down to Minnehaha Creek. That was the seventh.

IV. The Door

Edina · May 1980

She did not drink in Edina. She did not do much of anything in Edina. There was a cupboard over the refrigerator, and she knew what was in it, and how much was left in each bottle to the half inch.

Bud's war was with the creeping charlie. It came up from the creek side and went through his bluegrass like something poured. Every Saturday he went after it on his knees and pulled it up by the yard, like wet string. Wherever a joint of the stem had touched ground it had taken root, and wherever he left a joint behind it started over.

On a Saturday in May the doorbell rang. An old man stood on the step in a suit coat, eighty if he was a day, with a boy behind him carrying a black sample case. She had not seen a Watkins man in ten years. He lived with a daughter in Richfield by then and still worked a few streets, because he could not stop.

He looked at her through the screen. He did not speak to her. He turned to the boy.

Well, now, there is a wonderful thing, he said. *The girl out of Tollef Sande's hog house, and she's the wife of the assistant commissioner.*

He meant it kindly. He touched his hat and asked whether she was low on vanilla.

She did not hear him. She was seeing the gilt. She had not let herself think of that face in fifteen years, and it came back whole, the front feet set square and the light on the teeth and the corners of the mouth. Behind it came everything else, in its order, which she had never once let line up. There were the hens and the window. There was the lime in the privy and five white years. There was the dock, and the straw, and the gold bedspread, and the ring in the snow, and the box elder. She saw that it was one road and that she was still on it. The house in Edina was not the end of it. She saw what came next. She knew what the pig had been smiling at.

It frightened her more than anything in her life had, and it was the first fear that was ever any use to her.

She bought a bottle of vanilla, holding to the door frame. Then she walked across the lawn to where Bud knelt with his pile of vine.

I have to go somewhere, she said, *and I don't believe I'm coming back to this house. Will you let me?*

He sat back on his heels. He looked at her, and then up at the kitchen window, where the cupboard was that he had never mentioned.

I'll drive you, he said.

He drove her to Center City on the Monday in the Oldsmobile and carried her bag in. She did not live in his house again. Neither of them was ever sorry about the other. He sent her a card on that date every year until he died.

V. What Does This Mean

Center City, St. Paul and Hegre · 1980 *to* 1987

AT THE TREATMENT PLACE ON THE LAKE THE WOMEN READ THE book aloud every morning, around the room, a paragraph apiece. For two weeks she did not take in a word of it.

In the third week she was sitting by an open window. The reading came around the room toward her in one woman's voice and then another's, and all at once she was six years old with a pan of oyster shell. It was the same sound, a room full of people saying a thing and then saying what it meant. She had been hearing it through a wall her whole life. This time she was in the room. The woman next to her read.

> *Selfishness—self-centeredness! That, we think, is the root of our troubles. Driven by a hundred forms of fear, self-delusion, self-seeking, and self-pity, we step on the toes of our fellows and they retaliate.*
>
> *— Alcoholics Anonymous (1939), chapter 5*

The root, Glenna said out loud.

They let it pass. People said things in that room. But she had the first piece of it, and it did not get away from her again. She thought of her father and his corn knife.

She was six years at the rest. There was a halfway house in St. Paul and a job in a school lunchroom, and a meeting every night for the first two years. In the fall of 1986, after the strike at the Hormel plant in Austin had been broken and half of that country was not speaking to the other half, she went home. Her father was dead. She bought the little house in Hegre, where there were forty people left. That October she dug out the box elder by herself with a spade and a mattock. She went down four feet for it and burned the root in the garden.

That winter she drove to a book meeting in Albert Lea on Tuesday nights. A man was reading the doctor's letter from the front of the book, and he came to the words *an entire psychic change.* Glenna, at the far end of the table, looked for the thing in her that had always leaned toward the cupboard. She could not find it. She had had it pushed down before, for

years together, and she knew the feel of that. This was something else. There was nothing down there to push on.

She sat with her hands flat on the table. Nobody in the room noticed anything, and she did not mention it.

VI. Thirteen

Hegre · March 1997

She was sober almost seventeen years. She started the Thursday meeting in the basement of Hegre Lutheran, which by then had service once a month, and people drove to it from four counties. She never said much there. When a new woman came down the stairs shaking, Glenna went and sat by her, and that was about all anyone saw her do.

By March of 1997 the cancer was in her liver and she weighed ninety pounds. The women met at her house that Thursday afternoon, since she could not go out, and they asked her to tell it, all of it. She told it from her chair, beginning to end. At night she had them carry her over to the church. She sat at the front next to Morris T., who had read the opening of that meeting aloud every Thursday since it began, and the men asked her too. So she told it again.

I was born in my grandfather's house and we lost it. I was a girl with a pan of oyster shell under that window right there. I was a princess in Albert Lea. I was five years someplace so quiet I can't tell you where it was. I was a rich man's daughter-in-law on Fountain Lake for about a year. I was in the straw with a gilt. Then it was Golden Valley, and Rochester, and Duluth, and Two Harbors, and St. Paul, and my dad's back steps, and Edina. That's thirteen, up and down, and I never got anywhere on any one of them. Then an old man said a thing on my step and I was scared enough, finally, and I came in.

She rested a minute.

I'm done now. I don't mean sober. I mean it's finished. Don't any of you coast. Keep at it until it's finished.

They took her home. She died a little before four in her own bed, and it is said in the rooms that there was nothing left over.

The church is closed now. The meeting still has the basement on Thursdays, and Morris's grandson reads the opening. The windows down there are at the level of the grass. In warm weather they are propped open with hymnbooks, and anything going by in the yard can hear every word.

Background

The verses

> *As a tree, even though it has been cut down, is firm so long as its root is safe, and grows again, thus, unless the feeders of thirst are destroyed, the pain (of life) will return again and again.*
>
> Dhammapada 338, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He whose thirst running towards pleasure is exceeding strong in the thirty-six channels, the waves will carry away that misguided man, viz. his desires which are set on passion.*
>
> Dhammapada 339, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The channels run everywhere, the creeper (of passion) stands sprouting; if you see the creeper springing up, cut its root by means of knowledge.*
>
> Dhammapada 340, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *A creature's pleasures are extravagant and luxurious; sunk in lust and looking for pleasure, men undergo (again and again) birth and decay.*
>
> Dhammapada 341, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Men, driven on by thirst, run about like a snared hare; held in fetters and bonds, they undergo pain for a long time, again and again.*
>
> Dhammapada 342, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Men, driven on by thirst, run about like a snared hare; let therefore the mendicant drive out thirst, by striving after passionlessness for himself.*
>
> Dhammapada 343, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Walking into Rājagaha for alms, the Buddha saw a young sow wallowing in filth and smiled. Ānanda asked why. The sow, he said, had once been a hen that lived beside a hall and listened to a monk reciting; from the mere sound she was reborn a princess, Ubbarī. The princess saw a heap of maggots in a privy, held the sight in her mind, and reached the first absorption, and from that was reborn in a Brahmā heaven.

Then she fell, to a rich household and then to this sty. Standing in the street he spoke six verses on craving: the cut tree that grows again from its root, the streams that run everywhere, the creeper, the hare in the snare. The sow went on through seven more births, in the Golden Land, at Benares, in a horse dealer's house in one port and a mariner's in another, in a noble house in the capital of Sri Lanka, and at last as Sumanā, a villager's daughter whose village emptied out and who married the king's minister. A monk at her door remarked to his companions what a wonder it was that a young sow should be the minister's wife. She remembered everything, was shaken, got her husband's leave, and went forth. She won the first fruit on hearing one discourse recited and arahatship, back in her home village after the war, on hearing another; and on the day she died she told nuns and monks all thirteen of her lives and urged them to keep at the work. Here is the full commentary story. In this retelling the one who sees and smiles is the sow, and the thirteen lives are one woman's addresses.

Freeborn County, Minnesota

Southern Minnesota, *1956* to *1997*

Minnesota has crowned a state dairy princess, Princess Kay of the Milky Way, since 1954, chosen from among county princesses; several early ones came from Freeborn and Mower counties. The J. R. Watkins company of Winona sold liniment, vanilla, pepper and farm remedies door to door, was the largest direct-sales firm in the world in the 1940s, and went through bankruptcy and a sale in 1978. The Twins of 1965 took first place on July 1 and kept it, and their games went out over WCCO. A gilt is a young sow that has not yet farrowed, and the Chester White is an old American white breed. Tenant farmers in the Corn Belt customarily moved on the first of March. Creeping charlie, or ground ivy, roots at every joint of its stem, which is why pulling it does not work.

The book is *Alcoholics Anonymous*, first published in 1939; the main text of that first edition is in the public domain in the United States. "The Doctor's Opinion" at its front was written by William D. Silkworth, a New York physician, who described al-

coholism as "the phenomenon of craving." Hazelden opened in a farmhouse at Center City, Minnesota, in 1949, and the treatment approach that grew up there and at Willmar State Hospital spread so widely that the state was called the land of ten thousand treatment centers. "Geographic," for a move made to outrun one's drinking, is common talk in A.A. The strike at the Hormel plant in Austin, one county east of Albert Lea, lasted from August 1985 to September 1986, brought out the National Guard, and ended in defeat for the local. Hegre is an invented town, and so are Glenna Hovey, the Sandes, Arnold Enger and Bud Lindahl.

After the story of the young sow from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 338–343). The original. Quotations from *Alcoholics Anonymous* (first edition, 1939). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

24.3

The Watch Chain

> *Stand fast therefore in the liberty wherewith Christ hath made us free, and be not entangled again with the yoke of bondage.*
> *— Galatians 5:1*

Wie ich es gehört habe, on the Wissahickon.

I. The Watch

The Ridge above the Wissahickon · 1717–1723

Christoph Bender came up the river in the fall of 1717 at thirteen years old, alone, off a ship from Rotterdam on which his father and mother and a sister had died between the Downs and the Delaware Capes. The ship's master sold the other orphans' time to farmers on the wharf. Nobody would buy Christoph's, because he had the flux, and an old man in a brown coat who had come down to the river to sell bark and roots paid his passage money out of a cloth bag and walked him to Germantown, six miles, holding him up by the back of his collar.

The old man was Brother Wendel. He was one of the last of the learned men who had come over with the Magister in 1694 to wait in the forest for the end of the world. There had been forty of them then, and a log house on the ridge above the creek, forty feet square and set true to the compass, with a little room on the roof where one of them sat every night of the year with a brass telescope, watching the sky so that if the Bridegroom came at midnight their lamps would be found trimmed. The Magister had been dead nine years. Most of the forty had gone back into the world, to marry and to keep school and to plead in the courts and buy land, and the watch on the roof had not been kept for a long time. The log house leaned. A few old men still lived in caves and huts along the

creek below it, each by himself, and Brother Wendel was one. He was a physician. He gathered bark and roots up and down the Wissahickon and carried them to the market in Philadelphia, and with the money he bought books and orphans.

He kept the boy in his hut through the winter and cured him with a decoction of blackberry root, and in the spring he began to teach him to pray. It was not prayer as Christoph had learned it in the Palatinate. There were no words in it to speak. Brother Wendel sat on the floor of the hut with his back against the log wall and his hands open on his knees, and he told the boy to sit the same way, and to bring his heart to God the way you bring a coal to the hearth, and then to stop. The old man had a little book of the Magister's in his own hand, the method of inward prayer, and he would read from it in the evening, one sentence and then nothing for an hour.

> *Thus it is necessary in the Beginning to kindle the Fire by Working; but afterwards, when once it is kindled, to let it burn. When this is done, then the Soul has no more to do the whole Time of prayer but to remain in peace and Silence; endeavouring to continue in this loving Remembrance of God, who is so truly present in her, as He is in Heaven.*
>
> *— Johannes Kelpius, A Method of Prayer (English translation, 1761)*

Christoph had a gift for it that the old man had not seen in thirty years. By sixteen he could sit from Compline until the stars over the creek had turned a quarter of the sky, so still that a wood mouse came in and went over his foot and out again. Brother Wendel told him that he had kindled the fire, and that now it was burning by itself, and that he should be careful of nothing in the world except letting it go out. The boy believed him. There were four rooms in that silence, one behind another, each quieter than the one before, and by the time he was eighteen he could go into the fourth and stay.

Across the ridge, in a hut of chestnut bark near the spring, lived a widow named Anna Margaretha Ott, who had left the Palatinate in the great emigration of 1709 and come over by way of London and the Hudson, and

walked down into Pennsylvania alone after her husband died at the tar camps. She was older than Brother Wendel and nobody could say how much. She grew sage and comfrey and hyssop by her door and kept a goat. The brothers called her the Woman in the Wilderness, which was the name of the Magister's whole company, out of the twelfth chapter of the Revelation, and they had meant it as a joke the first year and had stopped meaning it as one. Brother Wendel had learned his prayer from the Magister, but he went across the ridge to her when he could not settle, and sat in her doorway while she shelled beans, and came back settled. She did not say much. Christoph went with him sometimes. She looked at the boy once, a long look, the year he was seventeen, and said only, *Dein Feuer brennt.* Your fire is burning.

II. Front Street

Philadelphia · 1723–1725

His mother's brother was a goldsmith in Philadelphia. Christoph had not known it until a German from Front Street bought dried snakeroot from Brother Wendel at the market and asked whose boy that was, and heard the name Bender, and said Jacob Kayser had a sister who married a Bender in Kreuznach. In the summer of 1723 Brother Wendel sent Christoph into the town with a parcel of medicines for the goldsmith's wife, who had an ague, and told him to come back the same night.

Jacob Kayser's shop was on Front Street above the High Street, in a brick house that faced the river, with a glass window of small square panes and a counter of walnut. Christoph stood at the counter with the parcel and waited, and while he waited he looked into the case.

He had never seen gold close. There were shoe buckles in the case and knee buckles, and a pair of sleeve buttons with a lion stamped in each, and a row of mourning rings with a little skull enameled black on the bezel and a name and a date inside, ordered by the dozen for a funeral, and a gold chain for a watch laid out in a long curve on green baize. The afternoon sun came in off the river through the small panes and lay

across the case, and the gold took it up and held it, and gave it back warmer than it had come in. Christoph stood and looked at the chain. He found that he had stopped hearing anything at all.

He did not go back that night. He told himself in the morning that he would go back after one more day, to help his uncle, and his uncle, who had no sons and liked the look of him, gave him a bed in the garret and a place at the end of the bench in the back room. Brother Wendel came into the town on market day a week later and stood in the street in front of the window in his brown coat and looked in, and Christoph saw him from the bench and did not go out, and the old man went away.

He was no good at the bench. Jacob Kayser set him to raising a cup, and he would not keep at it; set him to polishing, and he would polish a single buckle for an hour and sit and look at it. He liked the gold and he did not like work, and he had never in his life learned to work, only to sit. He slept late in the garret. He took a shilling from the drawer, and then four. In the spring of 1724 his uncle found two of the mourning rings missing, and put him out of the house with his bundle in the rain, and said in front of the apprentices that his sister's son was a drone and a thief and could starve.

He did not starve. There were men in the taverns along Dock Creek who had need of a quiet boy with clever hands who could stand still in a doorway without being noticed, and he could stand stiller than anyone they had ever seen. That summer he was taken with a silver spoon in his shirt and whipped through the town at the cart's tail, ten lashes at the Court House and ten at every corner of the High Street down to the river, and he did not cry out once, and the men from Dock Creek were pleased with him. In February of 1725 he and two others went in through the cellar of a shop in Second Street at night and came out with plate and a bag of coin. The other two were never caught. Christoph was caught the next morning with the coin in his coat and a gold watch chain around his neck under his shirt, laid against his skin, where he could feel it.

The law of the province had been mild once. In Penn's time a burglar paid back what he took, and more. But Penn had been dead seven years, and the Assembly had given Pennsylvania the law of England, and in

England a man was hanged for breaking a house in the night. The court sat in April. The jury was out a quarter of an hour.

III. The Cart

The High Street · April 1725

They brought him out of the jail on a market Wednesday, so that the most people would see. His arms were bound behind him at the elbows with a cord. He rode in a cart sitting on his own coffin, which was plain pine, with the rope already around his neck and its end coiled in his lap, and the cart went up the High Street at a walk between the market stalls, with the sheriff riding before it and the sheriff's men walking on either side with halberds and muskets. The town came out to see. People stood on the steps of the Court House and on the market benches and on the roofs of the stalls, and at every corner where the cart stopped they called things out to him, in English and German and Dutch, and boys threw what boys throw. A woman held up her child to see a thief who would be dead by noon.

Christoph sat on the coffin and shook. He could not stop it. It went through him in waves from the knees up, and his teeth went with it, and the crowd saw it and laughed, and he thought he would be sick on his own coffin before they ever got him to the gallows.

Brother Wendel was at the market with his roots.

He was seventy-four years old that spring, and his eyes were not good, but he knew the back of that head going by above the crowd. He left his basket on the bench. He went out into the High Street and through the people to the side of the cart, and walked beside it, an old man in a brown coat with his hand on the rail, and when one of the sheriff's men put a halberd across his chest he looked at the man and the man took it away again.

Loosen his arms, Brother Wendel said to the sheriff. *He will not run. He is done running.*

The sheriff looked down from his horse at the old hermit, whom half the town had bought physic from, and after a moment he nodded, and a

constable climbed up and slacked the cord at the boy's elbows, so that his hands came round in front of him and lay in his lap on the coiled rope.

Then Brother Wendel spoke to him in German, under the noise of the crowd, the way he used to speak in the hut, one sentence.

Christoph. Kindle it, and let it burn.

The boy turned his hands over on his knees, palms up, the way he had sat on the floor of the hut. He did not decide to. His hands remembered it before he did. He took one breath and then he took the next, and he brought his heart to it the way you bring a coal to a hearth, and then he stopped. The shaking went out of his knees. It went out of his teeth and his hands. He went into the first room of the silence, and found the door to the second standing open as if somebody had only stepped out, and went through, and through the third, and into the fourth, and stayed.

The cart came out past the last houses to the gallows. The hangman stood up in the cart and threw the rope over the beam and made it fast, and drew it up until it lifted the boy's chin, and got down. The sheriff's men made a ring around the cart with their halberds and their muskets, thirty of them, and around them the crowd stood thick to the edge of the common, two or three thousand people, the whole town. The sheriff read out the sentence in English. A minister offered to pray, and Christoph thanked him and said he was praying, and the minister looked at his face and got down.

He sat on his coffin with the rope drawn up under his jaw and his hands open on his knees, and he did not move. He did not shake and he did not weep and he did not look for anyone in the crowd. He looked straight ahead of him at nothing, and his face was quiet the way a pond is quiet in the early morning before anything has touched it, and the whole common, two thousand people who had come out to see a thief die, went still to look at him.

It was the sheriff's men who broke first. A Welshman at the near wheel said it out loud. *Look at him. Will you look at him.* And then the others, and then the crowd, all of it, shouting, the way a crowd shouts at a fire, not angry, only unable to keep still in front of a thing like that. *Look at the man. There are thirty muskets on him and he does not so much as blink.* Some-

body shouted for the Governor. More took it up. The sheriff sat his horse a long minute looking at the boy, and then he turned it and rode back into the town through the crowd at a canter, and the hangman, who did not know what to do, sat down on the tail of the cart and waited, and the crowd waited, and the boy sat.

The sheriff was gone an hour. When he came back he had a paper in his hand with a seal on it, and he read it out from the saddle, and what it said under all the words was that the Governor had heard the case and pardoned Christoph Bender of his life.

Let him down, the sheriff said.

• • •

The hangman climbed up to cast off the rope. Before he could reach it, before the constables had got through the crowd to the cart, the people near the wheels saw the boy lift his eyes from where they had been all that hour and look at something a little above the crowd, over toward the northwest, toward the Wissahickon hills.

Afterward the people on the common said many things about it. Most of them said they saw nothing. Some of them said they saw a light standing in the air above the heads of the people, a little above the height of the gallows beam, the light of the sun at noon gathered into the shape of a woman, an old woman in a countrywoman's cap with her sleeves rolled up, and the light came off her as it comes off water. A German woman from Germantown said it was the widow Ott from the Ridge, whom she knew by her cap, and that it could not have been, because the widow Ott had been seen at her spring that morning drawing water and had not been into the town in sixteen years. The boy said afterward only that she had spoken to him, in German, as it stands in Luther's Bible, and the English Bible has it so.

> *Stand fast therefore in the liberty wherewith Christ hath made us free, and be not entangled again with the yoke of bondage.*
>
> *— Galatians 5:1*

Christoph Bender sat on his coffin under the gallows with the rope still drawn up under his chin and looked at the light, and he saw the case in the goldsmith's window, the buckles and the black-enameled rings and the chain laid out in a curve on green baize, and the sun lying across it off the river. He saw the gold take up the light and hold it and give it back. He saw that it had never held anything of its own. It had all come in through the window. He saw the chain around his own neck, under his shirt, and the rope around it, outside his shirt, and saw that they were one rope, and had been since the afternoon he stood at the counter with Brother Wendel's parcel in his hands, and that he had walked out of the forest into it with his eyes open. And while he saw it, something in him that had been tied a long time came loose of itself, the way a knot does that someone has finally pulled from the right end.

Then he stood up on the coffin, and the rope slid off his neck and over his head as if it had never been made fast, and he went up.

He went up off the cart the way a heron goes up off a creek, slow at first and then not slow, over the heads of the sheriff's men and the muskets and the hangman with his mouth open, and over the crowd, and he went away northwest over the roofs at the edge of the town and over the fields toward the Wissahickon hills, until the people on the common could not see him against the sky. The hangman stood in the cart holding the empty rope. Under it, on the lid of the coffin, lay a gold watch chain, in a loose curve, where it had fallen.

IV. The Bean Basket

The Ridge · the next morning

The sheriff rode out to the Ridge the next morning with the Governor's paper in his coat. He could have sent a constable. He said afterward that he wanted to see. Brother Wendel walked beside his horse from the Germantown road. They found the boy where the woman in the market had said they would, across the ridge from the old leaning log house, at the chestnut-bark hut by the spring.

He was sitting on the ground in the doorway with his back against the post and his hands open on his knees. Anna Margaretha Ott was sitting on the bench beside him with a basket of last year's beans in her lap, shelling them into her apron, and the goat was eating the comfrey. Two or three of the old recluses had come over from their huts along the creek and were standing a little way off under the trees in their coats, not saying anything, as men stand at the back of a meeting.

The sheriff got down. He took out the paper and held it out, and Christoph looked up at him, and took it, and thanked him, and laid it on the ground beside him without unfolding it. Then he looked back at whatever he had been looking at before they came, which seemed to be nothing, the spring and the trees and the morning on the hill.

They stood there a long time, the sheriff and the old men, and nobody spoke. The sheriff said later that he had meant to say something to the boy about the mercy of the Governor and the amendment of his life, and found when he was standing there that he did not want to say anything to anybody, and did not for the rest of the morning, and rode back to the town without having said it. Brother Wendel sat down on the ground at the end of the bench.

Somewhere in that hour, the old men said afterward, the boy went into the fourth room and out the other side of it, where there was no room, and did not come back, though he was sitting there in front of them with his eyes open the whole time, and when the widow had finished her beans she got up and gave him the basket of empty pods to carry to the goat, and he got up and carried it.

Background

The verse

> *He who having got rid of the forest (of lust) (i.e. after having reached Nirvana) gives himself over to forest-life (i.e. to lust), and who, when removed from the forest (i.e. from lust), runs to the forest (i.e. to lust), look at that man! though free, he runs into bondage.*
>
> Dhammapada 344, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk who lives with the great ascetic Mahā Kassapa and has mastered the four meditative absorptions visits his uncle, a goldsmith, is taken with the gold ornaments in the house, and leaves the order. Too lazy to work, he is put out of the house, falls in with thieves and is caught. As he is led bound to the place of execution, beaten at every crossroads, Kassapa sees him, has his bonds loosened and tells him to take up his old meditation subject again. He regains the fourth absorption and sits among the raised weapons without fear, until the executioners, astonished, report him to the king, who sets him free. The Buddha then sends a radiant image of himself and speaks the verse, which plays on *vana*, both "forest" and "desire"; the man reaches the first stage of awakening where he sits, rises through the air to the Buddha, and becomes an arahant before the assembly. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Kassapa.

Germantown and Philadelphia, Pennsylvania

The Wissahickon and Philadelphia, 1725

In 1694 the mystic Johannes Kelpius brought a company of learned German Pietists to the Wissahickon Creek near Germantown to await the end of the world, a community remembered as the Society of the Woman in the Wilderness, after the twelfth chapter of Revelation. According to Julius Sachse's *German Pietists of Provincial Pennsylvania* (1895), their log tabernacle was forty feet square, set to the points of the compass, with a roof lantern where members watched the sky by night so that their lamps would be trimmed if the Bridegroom came. After Kelpius died in 1708 most of the brothers returned to the world, the watch was abandoned, and a few lived on as recluses along the creek. His *Method of Prayer* on inward, silent prayer was translated into English in 1761 and reprinted at Germantown in 1763. Brother Wendel, the widow Ott, Christoph Bender and the Kayser shop are invented. Germans had been coming since the Palatine emigration of 1709, and in greater numbers from 1717.

Under William Penn, Pennsylvania had the mildest criminal code in the colonies: property crimes were punished with restitution, and only murder carried death. That law expired with Penn in 1718, and under Governor William Keith the Assembly

made a large number of offenses capital, as in England. Pardons still came: in 1725 a woman convicted of burglary in Pennsylvania was pardoned on condition that she leave the colony.

After the story of the runaway bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 344). The original. Scripture from the King James Version and the English translation of Johannes Kelpius's *A Method of Prayer* (1761). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24.4

Correhuela

Strength is thine; thy fetters are loosed; thou hast every resource.
— Slok LIV of the ninth Guru's sloks

Así me lo contaron, in the Imperial Valley.

I. Thirty Hats

El Centro, California · a Saturday in November 1948

Thirty of them came in for the Guru's birthday. They came from Niland and Calipatria and the ditch camps east of Holtville, and four came the whole way from Casa Grande in a Ford truck with a cracked block, and they parked along the side street by the hall the Japanese families had built for their Buddha. The Japanese families had been sent to the camps in the war and had been made to sell it. The Punjabi farmers of the valley had bought it, and for one year now it had been their own temple, the only one south of Stockton.

They were old men, most of them. They had come to California before the first war, when a man from the Doaba could still get in, to pick and then to lease and then to grow cotton on land that the law said they could not own. So the land had gone into the names of bankers and lawyers, and later into the names of their own children as fast as the children were born. The law had also left them no way to bring a wife. The ones who married had married Mexican women from the cotton camps, and their sons were called Singh and served Mass.

They had come for the birthday, and they had come to see Doña Cuca.

Refugio Singh was fifty. She had crossed at Juárez in 1916 with her mother and three sisters, running from the fighting, and at twenty she had married Mota Singh, who had eighty acres of cotton in a lawyer's

name. All three sisters had married his partners. Half the men in the hall that night had been married in her kitchen. When two partners fell out over a lease they came to her table before they went to a judge, because she knew what each of them owed and to whom, and she was not afraid of any of them. Mota had been dead four years. She had made the county let her burn him, the way he wanted, and she still farmed the eighty acres, in lettuce now, and thinned it herself with the short hoe.

She fed them. Chicken with the yellow spice, and roti that she had always called tortillas and made no differently. She said little. When Inder Singh, whom the whole valley called Andrés, sat turning his plate and not eating, she looked at him and let him be.

Andrés was fifty-eight. He had left a wife four months gone with child in a village under the hills in 1913, for three years, to earn the price of some land. He had never seen the boy. The boy was thirty-five. Last year the new law had made Andrés a citizen, and in the spring he had put forty acres in his own name, the first dirt he had owned in his life. Now he could send for them or go home to them, whichever he chose. He had been choosing since April. There had been no letter since the summer the country was cut in two.

II. The Chain

Main Street · Sunday morning

In the morning the thirty walked uptown for tobacco and razor blades, in their good hats, and on Main Street outside the county jail they had to stop, because the sidewalk was shut off.

A gray bus stood at the curb with the state's name on it. Two deputies were bringing men out to it, eleven men on one long chain. Each had irons on his wrists, and a short chain between his ankles so that he walked like a man in a deep furrow, and the long chain ran through a ring at every belt. They were Mexicans mostly, and two Okie boys, and a Filipino. The ninth man was Kehar Singh of Calipatria.

All of them knew him. He had farmed lettuce on a lease in a white man's name with a partner from his own village, and in March, when the

check came, the two of them had quarreled at the headgate over whose the crop was, with nothing on paper to say, and Kehar had killed him with an irrigating shovel. He had got twenty years. He was a small, neat man. Someone had cut his hair for him in the jail.

He saw the hats. He could not stop walking, because of the chain, but he turned his face to them as he went, and he said across the sidewalk in the language of home what the ninth Guru had sent out of the prison in Delhi to his son.

> *My strength is exhausted, I am in chains, and have no resource.*
>
> *Saith Nanak, God is now my refuge; He will succour me as He did the elephant.*
>
> *— Slok LIII*

Every one of the thirty knew what came after that. It had been read at the end of every prayer they had ever held, in packing sheds and front rooms, for thirty-five years. Not one of them said it. A deputy put his hand on Kehar's shoulder and turned him to the step. He went up it one foot and then the same foot again, and the door folded shut, and the bus went north up the highway with its windows the color of the sky.

Nobody bought tobacco.

III. Two Fingers

The temple kitchen · that evening

THEY TOLD HER IN THE KITCHEN, AFTER THE MEAL, STANDING along the wall with their hats in their hands. Andrés was the one who asked it.

Doña Cuca, eleven men could not have broken that chain. A mule could not. Is there anything in the world that holds a man harder than that?

She was drying the big kettle. She set it down and went out the back door in the dark and came in again with something trailing from her fist. It was a piece of correhuela, the wild morning glory, a green string as

long as her arm with a few arrow leaves on it. It grew along the fence there as it grew along every fence in the valley.

Give me your hand.

She wound it four times around his wrist and tucked the end under.

Break it.

He turned his wrist and it parted. Some of the men laughed.

Two fingers, she said. *A child can do it. Now come out to my lettuce and get it out of the ground. Mota chopped it for twenty-six years and I have chopped it four. I have dug down for the root as deep as my shoulder and it was still going. It doesn't fight you. It gives every time you pull, and that is how it holds. It climbs what you planted and lies down on top of it and takes it to the dirt, and you can stand there and watch and never see it move.*

She picked up the kettle again.

That iron they put on Kehar this morning, they have a key for. They will take it off him tonight when he gets where he is going. Ask what he was wearing in March, at the headgate. Ask what any of you has on. She did not look at Andrés. *Forty acres. A son you can't picture. Did a deputy put that on you? Bishan, say the one Mota used to sing on the ditch. The one that asks who has a mother.*

Old Bishan Singh, who read for them, said it standing where he was.

> *Who hath a mother, father, son, or wife? who hath a brother?*
>
> *Of all the wealth, land, and property which thou deemest thine own,*
>
> *Nothing shall depart with thee when thou diest; why art thou wrapped up in them?*
>
> *— Hymn of Guru Teg Bahadur, Sarang I*

Wrapped up, she said. *He knew the plant.*

• • •

Then she told them Mota's story. He had told it irrigating, at night, when a man sits four hours by the water with nothing to do but stay awake. It was about a man from under the hills, in his grandfather's grandfather's time, and Mota never gave him a name.

The man was poor. His father was dead, and he worked other men's fields for wages and kept his mother. All he wanted was to go up into the mountains where the holy men live under the snow and own nothing. His mother would not hear of it. She brought him a wife he had not asked for, a good girl from decent people, and then his mother died.

So he said to his wife, *You are strong. You can work for wages as I do. I am going up.* She said, *I am carrying. Wait until it is born and you have seen its face, and then go.* He said he would. It was a boy. He said, *You have come through it safe. Now I am going.* She said, *Wait only until he is off the breast.* While he was waiting for that, she was carrying again.

Then the man thought, *If I wait until she says go, I will die in this house.* He did not say one word to her. He got up in the night and went. At the edge of the town the watch took hold of him, a man on the road at that hour with no bundle. He said, *Masters, I have a mother to keep. Let me go.* They let him go.

He stopped a while in a certain place, and then he went up, and he lived the way he had wanted to. They say that one day, sitting up there with nobody by, he said it out loud. *That was a hard one to break. Wife and son. I broke it.*

The first year we were married Mota told me that, Doña Cuca said, *and I said, so the wife is the chain. He said no. She only asked him to wait. He was the one who waited.*

She hung the kettle on its nail.

Mota never went up any mountain. He had me and seven children and the cotton. He said that man did it with his feet, and there is another way, sitting where you are, and it's harder. He said the Guru was sitting in an iron cage when he did it. And then the boy wrote back to him. Somebody should have called that across the street this morning. Kehar was asking for it. It was never about the iron.

Nobody moved. Then Bishan Singh said it, not loudly, to the kitchen wall.

Strength is thine; thy fetters are loosed; thou hast every resource;

Nanak, everything is in thy power; it is only thou who canst assist thyself.

— Slok LIV

IV. The Row

Doña Cuca's eighty acres · Monday, first light

ANDRÉS DID NOT SLEEP IN THE HALL WITH THE OTHERS. SOME time before morning he drove out the Holtville road, and when the sky went gray he was standing at the end of her lettuce, and she was already in it, bent double over the short hoe, a quarter of the way down the first row.

He did not have a hoe. He got down on his knees in the next row over.

The lettuce was up four inches. Every few feet a string of correhuela had come out of the ground beside a plant and gone up it, around and around, always the same way, and laid its own leaves over the top. He took hold of the first one to pull.

Don't yank, she said, without straightening. *You'll bring the lettuce.*

So he found the end of it with his thick fingers and turned it back off the plant, one turn and then the next, the way it had come. It took a long time. When it was free the lettuce stood up by itself, a little crooked. He held the vine. It had one flower on it, white with a pink stripe, just coming open because the sun was on it now.

He looked down the row. It ran a quarter of a mile to the ditch.

Now the next one, said Doña Cuca.

Background

The verses

Wise people do not call that a strong fetter which is made of iron, wood, or hemp; far stronger is the care for precious stones and rings, for sons and a wife.

Dhammapada 345, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *That fetter wise people call strong which drags down, yields, but is difficult to undo; after having cut this at last, people leave the world, free from cares, and leaving desires and pleasures behind.*
>
> Dhammapada 346, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, thirty monks from the country come to see the Buddha, and the next morning, walking for alms, pass the king's prison and see robbers and murderers bound in fetters, ropes and chains. That evening they ask whether any bond is stronger. These are nothing, the Buddha says, beside the longing for wealth, crops, sons and wives; and he tells of a poor man of long ago whose wife asked him to wait for one child and then another, until he rose in the night and left, talked his way past the city guards, and went up into the Himalaya. Read the full commentary story.

El Centro, California

The Imperial Valley, 1948

Punjabi men, most of them Sikhs from the Doaba, were farming cotton in the Imperial Valley by the 1910s. California's Alien Land Law barred them from owning farmland, so they held it through bankers, lawyers and, later, their American-born children; partners with nothing on paper sometimes ended in court or worse. Immigration law kept their wives in India, and several hundred married women of Mexican descent, founding the Punjabi-Mexican families of California. The Luce–Celler Act of 1946 at last let them become citizens, own land in their own names and send for relatives, a year before the Partition divided Punjab. The El Centro gurdwara opened in 1947 in a building that the town's Japanese American Buddhists had been forced to sell after their wartime removal.

The two sloks are numbers 53 and 54 of the fifty-seven attributed to Guru Tegh Bahadur, which close every complete reading of the Guru Granth Sahib. Tradition holds that he sent the first from his imprisonment in Delhi in 1675, and Macauliffe, whose 1909 translation is used here, follows the account that his young son Gobind Rai wrote the second in reply. Correhuela is field bindweed, whose roots run several

yards down and which regrows from any piece left in the ground. Kehar Singh, his partner and everyone else in the story are invented.

After the story of the Prison House from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 345–346). The original. Scripture from M. A. Macauliffe, *The Sikh Religion*, vol. IV (1909). Written by Claude
Fable 5.2.

24.5

The Linden Branch

Ca un cântec de sirenă,
Lumea-ntinde lucii mreje.
— Eminescu, Glossă

Așa am auzit, on Detroit Avenue.

I. The Photograph

The Romanian West Side, Cleveland · 1910

On Detroit Avenue, a few doors from the church, there was a photographer's studio with a window full of brides, and in the middle of the window, for three years, hung the photograph of Ileana Bratu.

She had come from Săliște, below the mountains in Transylvania, in the spring of 1907, to marry Ioan Bratu, who kept a boarding house for twenty-two men from Săliște and a grocery under it, at the corner of West Fifty-fourth Street. She was nineteen. She had brought with her one trunk, and in the trunk her mother's best ie, the white blouse worked at the shoulders and cuffs in black and red, so close that the linen hardly showed, and the week after the wedding Ioan took her down to the studio in it and had her photographed, standing, with one hand on a carved chair and her hair down her back as a girl wears it, though she was a married woman. The photographer asked to keep a print for the window. Ioan, who was proud, said yes.

The men in the boarding house called her Cosânzeana, after the princess in the stories, Ileana Cosânzeana, who is so beautiful you can look at the sun but not at her. They said it at first behind her back and then to her face, and she let them. The men who came over in the next three

years from Sălișteа had seen the photograph in the window before they ever saw her, and they said she was more beautiful than her picture, which was true. She knew it. On Sundays she stood at the front of St. Mary's with the married women, in a black silk kerchief that she wore a little farther back on her head than the others did, and she knew where the men were looking, and that was where she wanted them to look.

There was only one person in the colony she would not go near.

That was Maica Agafia, an old nun who had come out from the convent at Văratec in Moldavia in 1908, the only nun any of them had seen in America. Nobody quite knew why she had come. Some said she had a nephew at the ore docks who had been killed, and she had come to see the place. Some said her abbess had sent her. She was small and bent, in black, with a black veil over her cap, and she went to every death in the colony, and sat up all night by the body reading the Psalter, and walked behind the coffin to the cemetery. At a parastas the winter before, at the long table after the memorial, somebody had said what a beautiful corpse the dead girl made, and Maica Agafia had said, not loudly, *A face is lent. Ask the grave what it gives back.*

Ileana had heard about it the same evening. After that, if she saw the black veil coming along Detroit Avenue, she crossed the street.

II. The Wood on the Rocky River

West Fifty-fourth Street · spring and summer

Ioan Bratu was not a priest's son, but he had been raised to fear God and to give, and he did both. He had saved, and bought land, as men from Sălișteа did, and one of the pieces he had bought was eleven acres of beech and maple woods on the bluff over the Rocky River, west of the city, for which he had no use at all except that the beeches reminded him of home. In the summer of 1909 he had given Maica Agafia leave to live there. Some of the men from the boarding house went out on a Sunday and built her a hut of logs and boards under the trees, with a little porch and a shelf for an icon, and after that she lived in the woods

LIKE THE OLD HERMITS IN THE MOUNTAINS AT HOME, AND came into the city only for the dead.

People began to go out to her. They went out Detroit Avenue on the streetcar and walked the last of it, women mostly, at first, and then some of the men, on Sunday afternoons, and sat on the ground in front of her porch, and she talked to them a little, not much. They came back quieter than they went. Ioan went every Sunday he could. Ileana would not.

It grieved him. He did not know how to say so. He was a man who said things with money.

On Saturday nights a pair of lăutari played for the boarders in the big room over the grocery, a fiddler and a man with a cobza, Roma musicians from Sibiu who had come over in 1906 and played at every wedding on the West Side. In June Ioan gave them five dollars to make a song. He told them what to put in it. They made a doina, slow, the way the old ones are, about a wood of beeches over a river in a far country, so tall that the light came down through the leaves green, like water, and the moss was soft, and a spring came out of the bank, and the lindens were in flower and the bees were in the lindens, and an old woman sat there in the evening and anyone who came to her went home lighter. They played it every Saturday after that, last, when the men were quiet and had had their plum brandy.

Ileana heard it the first night from the kitchen. The second Saturday she came and stood in the door with her hands in her apron. The third Saturday she sat down.

It was the linden flowers that did it. There had been a linden at the end of her father's garden in Săliște. She had not thought of it in three years.

What wood is that? she said to the fiddler, when they had finished. *Where is it? Is it at home?*

The fiddler looked at Ioan, and Ioan looked at the floor.

It's your own wood, doamnă, the fiddler said. *On the Rocky River. Your husband's.*

III. The Girl with the Branch

The bluff over the Rocky River · a Sunday in July

She went the next day, in her good kerchief and the ie from the photograph, with two of the women from the boarding house. She told herself she was going to see the wood.

It was everything in the song. The beeches went up gray and smooth and the light came down green through them, and there was a smell of leaf mold and of water, and the river was loud below the bluff. A spring came out of the bank. At the edge of the trees by the hut there was a linden in full flower, and the bees in it made a sound like a held note on the fiddle.

Twenty or thirty people were sitting on the ground in front of the porch. Maica Agafia sat on the step in her black with her hands in her lap, talking to them in her small voice, and beside her, standing, a girl was fanning her with a branch of the linden to keep the flies off.

Ileana stopped where she was.

She had never seen the girl in the colony. She would have known. The girl was perhaps seventeen, in an ie like her own but finer, the work at the shoulders so close it looked like a single piece of red and black, and her hair was down her back. She was more beautiful than anyone Ileana had ever seen, or ever imagined, more beautiful than the photograph in the window, more beautiful than Ileana. Ileana knew it at once, the way you know the step is missing on a dark stair. Next to this girl, she was a kitchen girl. She was not a sixteenth part of it.

And she thought: they lied to me about the old woman. A face is lent, she said. And here she keeps the most beautiful girl in Cleveland standing beside her with a branch.

She did not hear a word Maica Agafia said. She did not sit. She stood at the back with the two women from the boarding house on either side of her and looked at the girl.

The girl was fanning slowly. The linden branch went back and forth. Ileana watched her arm, and her face, and her hair.

Then the face was not seventeen. It was twenty-five, a married woman's face, and the hair was under a kerchief. Then it was thirty-five, and there were two lines from the nose to the corners of the mouth, and the arm with the branch was thicker. The branch went back and forth. Then it was fifty, and the cheeks had fallen in where the back teeth had gone, and the hands on the branch had big knuckles and brown spots on them. The branch went back and forth, slower. Then the woman was very old and bent, older than the maica, and the eyes were cloudy, and she was trembling and could hardly lift the branch, and the fine red and black of the ie hung on her like a sack on a post. Then she sank down onto the porch step and lay there, and it was a body, the face the color of tallow, the mouth open. Then the flies came that the branch had been keeping away. Then it was not a face. Then it was a heap of bones in the rags of the ie, with the linden branch beside them, its leaves already curling in the heat.

Nobody else on the ground in front of the porch moved. Afterward the two women from the boarding house swore they had seen nothing but Maica Agafia on the step, talking, alone, and a fallen linden branch on the boards beside her.

Ileana stood in the green light and thought, very clearly, as if somebody had written it on a slate: *All of it in the time it takes to say the Our Father. There was nothing in it. There was never anything in it. And I have been living in it like a house.*

Maica Agafia had stopped talking. She was looking at her across the heads of the people.

Ileana, she said. She had never spoken to her before. *You thought there was something there that would stay. Look at it now.* She did not point. *That is a sack. It is a sack full of what the doctor sees and the woman who washes the dead sees. It leaks, at every opening it leaks, every day of its life, and it smells, and it gets sick, and it is only a fool who wants it. Look at it until you have seen it.*

Ileana looked. Something in her that had been held tight for three years let go, the way a fist lets go in sleep, and she sat down on the

ground where she was, among the others, in her good ie, on the beech mast.

The maica waited a while. The bees went on in the linden.

Then she said, to all of them but to Ileana, that people who want things cannot get out of the wanting by themselves. They go down in it like a spider going down its own thread, she said, the thread it spun out of its own belly; it thinks it is going somewhere, and it is only going down its own thread. And then, because she had been a long time among the educated nuns of Văratec and knew things by heart that she had not learned in a village, she said some verses of Eminescu, the poet, who had died the year she took the veil, and whose lady had come to Văratec that same summer and died there too, of grief, and was buried by the church. She said them in the plain way she said the Psalter over the dead, without making anything of them.

Ca un cântec de sirenă,
Lumea-ntinde lucii mreje;
Ca să schimbe-actorii-n scenă,
Te momește în vârteje;
Tu pe-alături te strecoară,
Nu băga nici chiar de seamă,
Din cărarea ta afară
De te-ndeamnă, de te cheamă.

— Eminescu, Glossă

Like a siren's song, the world spreads out its shining nets. Ileana understood every word. She had been in the net so long she had thought it was the sky.

Zică toți ce vor să zică,
Treacă-n lume cine-o trece;
Ca să nu-ndrăgești nimică,
Tu rămâi la toate rece.

— Eminescu, Glossă

Let them all say what they will say. So as to love nothing, stay cool to all of it. When the maica stopped, Ileana was sitting very straight on the beech mast with her hands open in her lap, and her face was perfectly still, and the two women from the boarding house, who had known her three years, said afterward that they had been afraid to speak to her. It was not that she looked unhappy. It was that she did not seem to be anywhere that they could reach.

IV. Ioan

West Fifty-fourth Street · the following week

She did not take off the kerchief. She did not go down to the studio and ask for the photograph, which hung in the window until the photographer took it down himself, in the fall, to make room. She cooked for twenty-two men and washed their shirts and swept, and did it all very well, and sat at night in the kitchen with her hands in her lap and the lamp out. She did not cry. She did not seem to be in any trouble at all. That was what frightened Ioan.

On the Sunday he went out to the wood by himself and sat on the porch step with Maica Agafia, two old Transylvanians, a long time without talking, the way men do at home.

What did you do to her? he said at last.

Nothing. She saw.

She doesn't eat.

She will eat. The maica turned her prayer rope through her fingers. *Listen to me, Ioan Bratu. You were good to me, so I will tell you plainly. She will not stay in your house now. It is not that she doesn't love you. There is nothing in your house she wants, and nothing in this city, and nothing in her own face. A woman who has seen what she saw either goes to the monastery or she goes to the cemetery. I have seen it before. There is no third road for her.*

Ioan sat with his big hands on his knees and looked down through the beeches at the river.

He was a man who said things with money. He took out his purse.

Not the cemetery, he said. *Let her go, then. Let her go to Văratec. I'll pay the ship.*

The priest at St. Mary's told him that no monastery would take a married woman without her husband's leave, in writing. Ioan wrote it at the kitchen table, with the priest spelling the long words. He kept the boarding house for thirty-one more years and never married again, and the men from Sălișteˇ said he had become a strange one, giving money to everybody, and going out to the wood on the Rocky River every Sunday of his life, long after Maica Agafia was buried, to sit on the step of the empty hut.

V. Văratec

Neamț, Moldavia · after

She sailed from New York in October with a letter from Maica Agafia to the abbess, and her trunk, and in the trunk her mother's ie, which she gave at Văratec to the sisters who did the embroidery, to unpick for the thread.

Văratec was a village of nuns, three hundred of them, in little whitewashed houses along lanes under the hills, each with its garden. She was given a garden. In it there was a linden.

She was tonsured as Monahia Agafia, at her own asking, after the old woman on the Rocky River. Visitors who came to Văratec in the years between the wars, when the convent was full of famous ladies from Bucharest going on retreat in good shoes, sometimes asked to be taken to the nun who had been in America, because they had heard she could answer anything. She could not answer everything. But she would let them sit on the bench under her linden and ask, and she would listen until they had heard their own question, and then say one thing. The ladies went home and quoted it at dinners, usually wrong.

There is a story that one of them, a beautiful young woman with a famous name, asked her once whether it was true that she had been the most beautiful girl in Cleveland, America, and that the old nun laughed, which she seldom did, and said, *For three years.* Then she reached up into the

linden and broke off a little branch with the flowers on it and gave it to her to keep the flies off.

The young woman carried it as far as the gate. By then the flowers had begun to brown at the edges, and she stood a moment and looked at them, and did not throw it away.

Background

The verse

> *Those who are slaves to passions, run down with the stream (of desires), as a spider runs down the web which he has made himself; when they have cut this, at last, wise people leave the world free from cares, leaving all affection behind.*
>
> Dhammapada 347, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Queen Khemā, wife of King Bimbisāra of Magadha, is so proud of her beauty that she will not go near the Buddha, because she has heard that he finds fault with beauty of form. The king has songs made in praise of his Bamboo Grove, which he had given to the Buddha, and when she hears them she asks what grove they are singing of; it is her own. When she goes, the Buddha makes a woman appear beside him, more beautiful than Khemā, fanning him with a palm-leaf fan, and Khemā cannot look away. The Buddha then ages the woman before her eyes to an old woman and at last to a heap of bones. Khemā sees that there is no core in the body, and the Buddha speaks a verse on the body as a sick, leaking thing that only fools desire, and then the verse of the spider and its web. She attains awakening. The Buddha tells the king she must now either go forth or pass away, and the king says, let her go forth. She became the nun the Buddha named foremost in wisdom. Read the full commentary story, or about Khemā.

The maica's verses are from *Glossă* (1883) by Mihai Eminescu, Romania's national poet, quoted in the Romanian; the English in the story is a plain gloss, not a published translation. Eminescu died in June 1889. His beloved, the poet Veronica Micle, withdrew after his funeral to the convent at Văratec, died there that August, and is buried in its cemetery.

Cleveland, Ohio

Romanian Cleveland, 1910

By the First World War about 12,000 Romanians lived in Cleveland, most of them peasants from Transylvania, then part of Austria-Hungary. The largest settlement was on the West Side, between West 45th and West 65th streets on either side of Detroit Avenue, near the factories and docks where the men worked; most of the early immigrants were young men who lived in boarding houses run by families from their home districts. In 1904 they founded St. Mary's, the first Romanian Orthodox parish in America, and built its first church on Detroit Avenue. See Romanians in the Encyclopedia of Cleveland History and St. Mary's Romanian Orthodox Church on Cleveland Historical.

Văratec, in Neamț County, was founded in 1785 and grew into a village of nuns living in small houses along lanes around the church; in 1909 it had 304 nuns and sisters, and it was long known for its embroidery and weaving. In Orthodox tradition, as in Catholic, a married person may enter monastic life only with the consent of the spouse.

After the story of the Elder Khemā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 347). The original. Verses from Mihai Eminescu, *Glossă* (1883), in the Romanian. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24.6

Cloud of Witnesses

> *Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers: the snare is broken, and we are escaped.*
> *— Psalm 124:7*

Thus it was told me, on the Point at Newport.

I. The Benches

Newport, Rhode Island · summer 1754

Once a year, or once in two years, a company of rope-dancers and tumblers came up the coast from the southern colonies and played a week at Newport, on the open ground below the Colony House at the head of the Long Wharf. Their master was a Frenchman out of London named Garnier, and they were eleven in all, with three wagons, a sea-chest of spangles and a great many ropes. They stretched the tight rope between two masts and the slack rope between two others, and they set up a spar of sixty feet in the middle of the ground and stayed it with lines to the corners like a ship's mast. People came in from Portsmouth and Middletown and over the ferry from Jamestown, and they stood on benches set on top of other benches and threw coppers and Spanish silver and the Colony's paper money, which was worth so little by then that a gentleman would throw it by the handful and think nothing of it.

On the fourth day Garnier's daughter climbed the spar. She went up it hand over hand with her feet bare, turned over once in the air at the top, and came down standing on the cap of the mast, on a board no wider than a Bible, sixty feet over the cobbles. Then she danced there. She sang a French song and danced to it with her arms out, stepping on the air be-

side the board and back onto it, and the wind off the harbor took her skirts and the song both.

Edmund Lisle was standing on the top of a stack of benches with his friend Caleb Hart, eating oysters out of a paper. He was twenty-two. His father was Josiah Lisle, who owned a distillery on Thames Street and a third share in four ships, and the ships went out to the coast of Guinea with rum and came home by way of Barbados, and the Lisles had a house with a carved doorway and a man named Cudjo, whom they owned, to open it. Edmund watched Nan Garnier dance on the air, the way she used her hands and her feet, and he dropped the paper of oysters and did not pick it up.

He went home and lay down on his bed in his boots.

If I can have her I'll live, he said. *If I can't I'll die here.* And he would not eat.

His mother sat by the bed and said, *Ned, don't be a fool. We'll find you a girl of our own sort, with a portion.* His father stood in the door and said worse than that, and then said all of it again the next day, and Edmund lay with his face to the wall and drank only water. On the sixth day Josiah Lisle sent for Caleb Hart, counted a thousand pounds in Rhode Island bills into a leather bag, and said: *Take this to the Frenchman and tell him to give his girl to my son.*

Garnier was mending a rope in the back of a wagon. He looked into the bag, then at Caleb, and then he laughed.

Old Tenor, he said. *There's not forty pound sterling in it. And I don't sell my daughter for money, not for good money either. But if it's true he can't live without her, let him come along with us. If he'll do that, I'll give her to him.*

Caleb took the word back. Edmund got up off the bed. *Of course I'll go.* His mother wept and his father swore and neither of them could stop him. He put on his oldest coat and walked down to the Long Wharf, where the company was loading for New York, and Garnier married his daughter to him in the cabin of the sloop before they cleared the harbor, by the sloop's master, with the tumblers for witnesses.

II. The Wagon

The road · 1754–1755

They played New York and Perth Amboy and Philadelphia, and went down through the Jerseys and Maryland to Annapolis and Williamsburg, and the next spring north again. They played courthouse greens and tavern yards and fairs, wherever the magistrates would let them, and left in the night wherever they would not.

Edmund drove the lead wagon. Wherever they stopped he cut grass and carried water for the horses. Wherever they played he set up the masts and the scaffolds and stayed the spar, swept the ground, took the money at the rope, and when it was over he struck it all and loaded it again. He had never done a day's work in his life. His hands bled for a month and then were horn.

In the spring at Annapolis Nan had a son. They named him Josiah, for Edmund's father, who did not answer the letter. Nan went back up on the rope three weeks after, and in the evenings she sat on the wagon step with the boy on her knee and bounced him and sang to him. She made the songs up as she went, in English and in French, to old tunes.

Hush, my little carter's son,
carter's son, carter's son,
son of a hewer of wood and drawer of water,
son of a know-nothing, hush.

Edmund was greasing a wheel. He listened to it three nights running.

Is that me in the song?

Yes, that's you.

Then I'll run off and leave you.

Go or stay, said Nan. *What is it to me?* And she sang it again, and the boy laughed. She was the best rope-dancer between Boston and Charles Town and she knew it. She brought in more money in a week than the rest of the company together, and every man on every bench in every town looked up at her as if she were the moon. She did not need him for anything.

He sat a long time on the wagon tongue in the dark. *Why is she so proud?* he thought. And then, because he was not a fool, only young: *Because of what she can do up there.* And then: *Very well.*

In the morning he went to his father-in-law. Garnier looked at him a while, and looked at his hands, and nodded.

He was a year learning. He fell off the slack rope at Elizabeth Town and broke two ribs. He fell off the tight rope into a hay wagon at New Brunswick, on purpose, Garnier said afterward, which was the first thing he had done right. He learned the balance on the pole and the turn in the air and the lighting on the cap of the mast, and how to stand up there in a wind. He learned it on a twelve-foot pole and then a twenty and then a forty. Nan watched him from the wagon step with the boy and did not sing the song anymore, but she did not say anything else either.

In the summer of 1756 he played the spar alone at Providence, and the people of Providence stood on their benches and roared. Then the company went down the bay to Newport.

III. The Spar

Newport · Yearly Meeting week, 1756

The war with France had been declared that spring, and every wharf in the town was fitting out a privateer. Edmund got a sixty-foot topmast out of a brig at the Long Wharf that would not be ready for sea for a month, and he had the crier go through the town and printed bills put up on the doors of the taverns: *Seven Days Hence, on the Ground below the Colony House, Mr. EDMUND LISLE, Son of a Merchant of this Town, will Perform upon the Spar.* His father tore the bill off the door of the distillery with his own hand. His mother read it at the window and sent him a cold chicken by Cudjo.

It was the week of the Yearly Meeting, when the Friends of all New England came to Newport to sit together in the Great Meeting House, from Nantucket and Dartmouth and Lynn and Smithfield, and every Quaker house on the Point had six to a bed. So the town was full. On the seventh day the people built the benches up three and four high around

the ground, and stood on them, and sat on the Colony House steps, and climbed the rigging of the ships at the Long Wharf to see.

Among the Friends that week was an old woman from the mainland named Mercy Dunbar, a public Friend, which is to say a minister, who had traveled in the ministry for forty years from Carolina to Nova Scotia with a minute from her meeting in her pocket and some other Friend always beside her for company. She was seventy-seven. Her companion that summer was Deborah Pell of Nantucket, a widow of fifty, broad as a door and nearly as tall, whose husband had gone down with a whaling sloop and who had carried the oars in her own boat since.

On the morning of the seventh day Mercy Dunbar woke before light in a Friend's house on the Point and lay still a long while with her eyes open. Then she said to Deborah, who was dressing: *We'll go up through the town this forenoon.*

There's a rope-dancer on the Colony House ground, said Deborah. *The whole town's gone to it. Friends are advised to keep away.*

I know it, said Mercy Dunbar. *Get thy bonnet.*

• • •

Edmund went up the spar in white stockings and a scarlet jacket sewn all over with spangles, that had been Garnier's. He went up it the way Nan had gone up it two summers before, hand over hand, and the benches went quiet under him. At the top he stood on the cap, on the board, and let go of the mast with both hands, and looked down.

He could see the whole town. The harbor full of masts. The roof of his father's house on Thames Street and the smoke of the still-house behind it. The Long Wharf, Goat Island, the fort, the Jamestown ferry coming over. Two thousand faces turned up at him like plates on a dresser. Somewhere on the ground below was Nan, with the boy on her hip, looking up. He raised one arm to the crowd for the noise, and they gave it to him, and he bent his knees and went up into the air and turned over seven times, one after another, and came down standing on the board sixty feet over the cobbles with his arms out.

Nobody shouted. Nobody threw anything. He looked down.

Mercy Dunbar was coming up the slope from the Long Wharf with Deborah Pell beside her and a few other Friends behind, a small old woman in a grey gown and a plain bonnet, walking slowly with a stick. She was not doing anything. She was only walking up the hill. And every face on the benches had turned away from the spar to look at her, all together, the way a field of barley turns in one wind. People on the Colony House steps stood up to see her better. A sailor in the rigging of a snow at the wharf hung out over the yard by one hand with his mouth open. Not one of them was looking at Edmund Lisle.

He stood on the cap of the mast and felt it go out of him like water out of a cracked jug. *A year,* he thought. *Two broken ribs. A year of Elizabeth Town and New Brunswick, and an old Quaker woman walks up the hill and they turn around to look at her bonnet. It's failed. The whole of it has failed.*

IV. The Invitation

The Colony House ground · the same forenoon

Mercy Dunbar stopped at the edge of the crowd and looked up at him a long while with her hand shading her eyes. Then she said something to Deborah Pell, and Deborah came forward through the benches, and the people let her by, and she went straight across the empty ground to the foot of the spar and stood there with her feet apart and put back her head and called up to him, in a voice that had called across a good deal of water.

Look down here, Edmund Lisle! Thou that art so strong on the rope! Make a stage for the people! Make them laugh!

Edmund looked down at her. Something came back into him all at once, warm, the way blood comes back into a hand. *Even the Quakers want to see it,* he thought. *The old woman wants to see me do it.* And he called down from the cap of the mast:

Look up here, Friend! Thou that art so wise and strong! I'll make a stage for the people! I'll make them laugh!

And he went up off the board into the air and turned fourteen times, over and over, so fast the spangles on the scarlet jacket made one ring of

light around him, and came down standing on the cap of the mast with his arms out, and the benches came back to him with a roar that sent the gulls up off every roof on the harbor.

Mercy Dunbar had come forward to the foot of the spar. When the noise was gone she spoke up to him. She did not raise her voice much, and yet the ones who were there said afterward that everyone on the benches heard every word of it, and so did the sailors in the rigging, and so did Josiah Lisle, who was standing with his hat over his face at the corner of Thames Street and had sworn he would not come.

Edmund. Let go of what's behind thee. Let go of what's before thee. Let go of where thou standest now. And then she said it the way she would have said it in meeting:

> *Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us, Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith; who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is set down at the right hand of the throne of God.*
>
> *— Hebrews 12:1–2*

Edmund heard it standing on the board on the top of the mast, sixty feet over the cobbles, with nothing in his hands.

He let go of Thames Street and the carved doorway and the bag of Old Tenor. He let go of the carter's son and the know-nothing and the song on the wagon step. He let go of the year and the broken ribs and the fourteen turns and the roar, and of whatever was coming tomorrow, and of the board under his feet, and of the boy, and of Nan. He let go of Edmund Lisle. Two thousand people were looking up at him and there was nobody there for them to see. He stood on the cap of the mast in the wind off the harbor, and it was the stillest he had ever been in his life.

Those who were nearest said that his face changed. Some said it went pale, and some said it went bright, and one Friend from Dartmouth who wrote it down in a letter that night said only that it looked like the face of

a man who has been a long time in a dark room when somebody opens the shutter.

It was not only his face. Of the two thousand on the benches that forenoon, a great many went home quieter than they had come, and could not have said why. Men who had come to see a merchant's son break his neck walked down Thames Street with their hats in their hands. That year more strangers sat down on the back benches of the Great Meeting House than anyone could remember, and some of them stayed, and the Friends of the Point, who kept careful books, could never account for it.

V. The Ground

The foot of the spar

Then he came down. He did not climb. He walked off the board onto the stays as if they were a staircase and came down the line to the ground, hand over hand and sometimes no hands at all, and stepped off onto the cobbles and went across to where the old woman stood and knelt down in front of her.

Let me come with thee, he said. *Let me be one of you.*

Mercy Dunbar put out her right hand and he took it. *Come then, Friend,* she said.

This is the part that people would not agree about afterward and that the Friends never put in any minute. A good many people on the benches swore to it, and the sailor in the rigging of the snow swore to it, and Caleb Hart, who was not given to fancies, swore to it all his life: that when Edmund Lisle stood up from his knees he was not wearing the scarlet jacket or the white stockings or the spangles, but a plain coat of grey drugget and a broad hat, like any Friend from the Point. And that his hair, which had been as brown as a chestnut, was white, and his face was the face of a man of sixty, quiet and lined and very kind. And then they looked again and he was Edmund Lisle, twenty-four years old, in a scarlet jacket, holding an old woman's hand. And yet they could not get the other face out of their eyes, and when they met him on the street in after years, grey-coated, they said they knew it again.

Deborah Pell and the other Friends walked back down to the Point with the two of them that afternoon. On the way the young Friends from Lynn and Dartmouth fell in alongside Edmund and asked him what they had all been wanting to ask.

Friend Lisle. When thou camest down off that mast with no hands. Wast thou not afraid?

No, said Edmund. *I wasn't afraid.*

The young Friends looked at each other. Friends do not say what is not so, and they are hard on one another about it. When they reached the house on the Point they went to Mercy Dunbar where she sat by the hearth with her shoes off.

He says he had no fear coming down. Sixty feet with no hands. That is not the truth, and we think he should not be let to say it.

Mercy Dunbar looked at them over her spectacles. *Friends,* she said, *when everything that tied a man is cut, there's nothing left in him to tremble.* And she said:

> *Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers: the snare is broken, and we are escaped.*
>
> *— Psalm 124:7*

VI. The Smile

The Point · after Yearly Meeting

The talk went all through the Quaker houses on the Point that week, and the young Friends kept it up longest. How could a man who had it in him to come to that in a single forenoon have run off down the coast after a rope-dancer's girl, and carried water for a Frenchman's horses for two years? And if he had been that kind of man, how had he come to it at all?

Mercy Dunbar heard them at it one evening and asked what they were talking about, and they told her.

It's the one thing, she said. *Both of them.* And she told them a story.

When she was a girl of twenty, she said, Friends raised the Great Meeting House here on the Point, and Friends came from all over the colony with wagons of food to feed the men who were raising it. On the road from Portsmouth she was walking with an old public Friend from England who had come over in the ministry. A young man and his wife came up behind them with a cart full of bread and cheese and salt fish for the raising. The young woman saw the old Friend walking and said to her husband: *Look, there's a minister going in, and we've a whole cart of victuals. Give him something.* So the husband got down and filled the old man's hat with bread and cheese, and the two of them stood in the road and said to him: *Friend, let us come one day to what thou hast come to.*

The old Friend looked at the two of them a long while, and then he smiled. It was a broad, sweet, foolish smile, Mercy Dunbar said, like a boy at a fair, and she had never seen a Friend smile like that before or since.

The young woman looked at him and said to her husband, under her breath, as they went on up the road: *Didst thou see him grin? He's no minister. He must be some kind of play-actor.*

And the husband said, *He must be, my dear.* And laughed, and went on up to the raising with his cart.

Who were they? said one of the young Friends.

I never knew their names, said Mercy Dunbar. *They're the same two as always.* And she would not say any more about it, then or later, though she lived three years longer.

• • •

Nan Garnier sat on the wagon step on the Colony House ground the evening after it happened, with the boy asleep on her lap and the spar still standing in the dusk with nobody on it, and her father struck the rest of the rig around her. She had not gone down to the Point. She had not been asked.

She sat there until it was dark. Then she said to her father: *Wherever he's gone, I'll go there too.*

Garnier did not argue. He had seen her face when the old woman spoke.

She took off the spangled slippers and set them on the wagon step side by side, and walked down Thames Street to the Point in her stockings with the boy on her shoulder, and knocked at the door.

• • •

They were both received into membership by the monthly meeting in the spring, after the usual waiting, and the usual visits, and a good deal of talk. Within ten years each of them had been acknowledged a minister. Edmund traveled in the ministry as far as Georgia, always with some Friend beside him for company, and had nothing to say about the rope to anyone who asked. Nan traveled it with the women Friends from Nantucket to the Carolinas, and spoke in meeting so seldom that when she rose, the old Friends said, you could hear the benches creak all through the house as people leaned forward.

The spangled slippers stayed in the bottom of a chest in the house on the Point for sixty years. Their granddaughter found them there when she was a girl, and put them on, and walked the length of the ridgepole of the barn in them one summer afternoon, barefoot inside the satin, with her arms out, while her grandmother stood in the yard below in her grey gown and shaded her eyes and watched her the whole way across, and did not call her down.

Background

The verses

> *Give up what is before, give up what is behind, give up what is in the middle, when thou goest to the other shore of existence; if thy mind is altogether free, thou wilt not again enter into birth and decay.*
>
> Dhammapada 348, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has cut all fetters, who never trembles, is independent and unshackled.*
>
> Dhammapada 397, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Uggasena, a rich man's son of Rājagaha, falls in love with an acrobat's daughter he sees dancing on top of a pole. He refuses food until he can have her, and her father agrees only if he will travel with the troupe. He drives their carts and hauls their gear, and his wife mocks him in songs to their baby son. Stung, he learns the art himself and comes home to perform on a pole sixty cubits high. At the height of his act the Buddha enters the city, and the whole crowd turns to look at him. The Buddha sends the Elder Moggallāna to invite Uggasena to go on. He turns fourteen somersaults, and the Buddha tells him to let go of past, future and present. Uggasena is freed where he stands, comes down unafraid and is ordained. When the monks doubt his claim that he felt no fear, the Buddha speaks the second verse. A past-life story tells of a young couple who fed an elder on their way to work at a shrine, and when he smiled, called him an actor. Read the full commentary story, or the entry on Uggasena in the Dictionary of Pāli Proper Names.

Newport, Rhode Island

Newport, 1756

By the middle of the eighteenth century Newport was one of the busiest ports in British America, with a population of 6,753 in 1755. Much of its wealth came from the triangle trade: molasses from the Caribbean was distilled into rum, the rum was shipped to West Africa, and it was traded there for captive people. In 1764 the town had twenty-two rum distilleries. Rhode Island's paper money, the "Old Tenor" bills, had lost so much value that when the colony converted them to lawful money in 1763 it took twenty-six and two-thirds Old Tenor shillings to make one (Rhode Island pound). The town's Colony House, built in 1739, stood at the head of the open ground where the Long Wharf ran out into the harbor.

Quakers had been welcome in Newport since 1658, and they rose high in its trade and government. Their Great Friends Meeting House, raised in 1699, is the oldest surviving house of worship in Rhode Island. Each year it hosted the New England Yearly Meeting, when Friends from all over the region crowded into the town. Recognized ministers, women as well as men, were called "public Friends." Many

traveled in the ministry for months or years at a time, carrying a certificate from their monthly or quarterly meeting and relying on the hospitality of Friends along the way. Newport had no theatre of its own in these years. When a London company of players opened a playhouse on Easton's Point in 1761 in defiance of a town council vote, the colony soon answered with a law against stage plays that stopped performances for decades.

After the story of Uggasena from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 348 and 397). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24-7

The Near Bank

> *Shake off the chains with which ye are bound, and come forth out of obscurity, and arise from the dust.*
> — *2 Nephi 1:23*

The way it was told to me, on the Malin road.

I. The Dinner Calendar

Malin, Klamath County, Oregon · June 2022

Elder Bowman was nineteen and came from a seed-potato farm outside Sugar City, Idaho. His brother had served in the same mission six years ahead of him, and had been the kind of missionary a ward remembers, so that when the younger one stood up to introduce himself in sacrament meeting an old sister in the second row said, quite loud, *Oh, it's the little Bowman.* It stuck. He did not mind. He had been the little Bowman all his life. He had also shot a bow since he was six years old, and had twice been state champion in the 4-H barebow, and the fall he was fourteen he had put an arrow through a cow elk at forty yards across a draw, but he did not bring that up, because his brother had told him that nobody in the mission field wants to hear about your elk.

He had been out nine months. His companion that transfer was Elder Pappas, from The Dalles, a calm, heavy-shouldered boy who wanted to be a diesel mechanic and read the scriptures the way he would read a service manual, slowly, looking for the torque specs.

Their area was the whole south end of the county, down to the California line: Merrill, Malin, the farms along the Lost River, and the dry bed of what had been Tule Lake before the government drained it for homesteads. They lived in a single-wide on Brother Dalton's place, a mile

out of Malin. It was the second summer of the shutoff. The year before, for the first time since water first ran in it in 1907, the Bureau had kept the A Canal shut the whole season, and this year there was a trickle, and the fields that did not have a deep well under them had gone to weeds and blowing dirt. The farmers who had deep wells ran them day and night, and the water table went down like a drink through a straw. All over the basin the shallow house wells were sucking air. People hauled water in the beds of their pickups. They showered at a sister-in-law's.

The well at the single-wide quit on the ninth of June. The kitchen tap coughed twice and ran brown and stopped. Brother Dalton came over and listened to the pump and took off his cap and looked at the inside of it. The driller in Klamath Falls had a list eleven months long, he said. The county had a tank with their name on it, a five-hundred-gallon poly tank that a truck would come and fill, and it would be delivered when it was delivered.

The ward fed the elders by a calendar that hung on the Relief Society board, a square for every night, and whoever signed the square brought dinner. That Thursday the square said *Ruiz*. Sister Ruiz worked swing shift at the door plant in Klamath and could not sit down with anybody, so she left two foil plates of enchiladas in a cooler on the step, with a note. They carried them to the meetinghouse to eat at the kitchen counter there, where it was cool. The custodian had taped a sheet of paper over the kitchen sink. *Bldg well low. Water OFF except Sundays.*

They stood there with the foil plates, and neither of them had had a drink since breakfast.

Havliks', Brother Dalton said on the phone. *A mile past me, the white house with the windbreak. They've got an ag well goes down six hundred feet. Old Frank Havlik never turned anybody away from that pump in his life. He passed in February. I guess the girl's still there.*

II. Water

The Havlik place · June and July

Malin was settled in the fall of 1909 by sixty-five Bohemian families who came out from the Midwest to farm the lake bottom. They named it for a town at home, and they found horseradish growing wild there the size of a man's arm and took it for a sign. A Havlik had been one of the sixty-five. The house was his, a tall plain farmhouse with a porch on two sides and a row of Lombardy poplars the wind had been working on for a hundred years.

The woman who came around the corner of it, wiping her hands on her jeans, was perhaps twenty-seven. She had her hair tied up in a bandanna and dust to the elbows. She looked at the white shirts and the black name tags and the four blue jugs.

You're the ones on Dalton's place, she said. *I heard his well went. Pump house is around the side. The hydrant sticks, you have to lean on it.*

Her name was Tess. That was the first day, and all of it, except that when they had the jugs in the trunk she walked out to the car and said, *When you need water again, come here. Don't go anyplace else. I mean it. That well's the one thing on this place that works.*

They needed water every second day. Four jugs, twenty gallons, was drinking and dishes and a spit bath, with enough over to flush once at night.

The hydrant was at the pump house, fifty yards off across the yard, and it ran slow. Elder Pappas took the hydrant. He was better at leaning on it. That left Elder Bowman on the porch steps, in plain sight, holding the caps, and it left Tess Havlik, who seemed always to have just come in from something.

The second time she brought out two glasses of water with ice, and stood while he drank his. The third time it was lemonade. The week after, there was a plate of koláče on the porch rail, apricot and poppy seed, from a card in her great-grandmother's handwriting that she had to hold up to the window to read. Then one evening when they drove in there was a card table on the porch with an oilcloth on it and two kitchen

chairs, and she fed them. Chicken in paprika gravy, with dumplings sliced off a loaf with a thread, and a dish of fresh horseradish she had grated out by the shop with the wind behind her, which brought the tears straight down Elder Pappas's face.

We're not supposed to go inside, Elder Bowman had told her, the second day, red to the collar. *Without another man there. It's a rule.*

So don't come inside, she said. And had moved the table out.

She did not eat with them. She brought a third chair and set it at the corner of the table, near his, and sat with her boots up on the rail and talked, while Elder Pappas went off to see about the jugs.

She had been in Portland six years, doing something with spreadsheets for a company that sold running shoes. She came home in 2020 when her father had his stroke, to run the place for a few months, and it had been two years. One pivot of alfalfa still green off the deep well. Everything else fallow. Her mother was in Arizona with a man named Gary. Her brother was in Boise and called on Sundays.

You want to know the truth? she said. It was past eight and the light was coming in level under the porch roof, through the poplars. *It is so lonesome in this house. You two are the only people who've driven up that road on purpose since the funeral. I don't count UPS. Some days I talk to the pump.*

He laughed. She looked at him when he laughed, a moment longer than a person needs to.

You grew up on a place like this.

Yes ma'am. Potatoes.

I can tell. You looked at that wheel line when you drove in like it owed you money.

It did. The far wheel line had a flat mover and two blown gaskets, and he could have had it rolling in an afternoon. He knew how to do every single thing that place needed. He lay on his back in the single-wide that night, on top of the sheet, with the box fan going, and fixed the wheel line in his head. Then he reset the pivot nozzles. Then he was standing in the pump house door in a pair of work gloves and she was coming across the yard with two glasses. He turned over. He fixed the wheel line again.

Elder Pappas, in the other bed, said into the dark, *We should be bringing a member up there with us.*

We're on the porch. You're fifty yards off.

I know where I am, said Elder Pappas.

III. Yellow

Malin · the end of July

By the last week of July Elder Bowman was not eating what the calendar brought. He pushed Sister Dalton's funeral potatoes around the plate and said they were good. He was awake at two and again at four. In the mornings he sat through his hour of study with the book open at the same page of Mosiah and his eyes on the wall above it, and on the days that were not water days he was short with people, and on the days that were he shaved twice.

He had stopped fixing the wheel line. He had moved on to the conversation with his father, and the one with his brother. He had worked out that a man could be released honorably for a number of reasons, and that fifteen months was not so long to give back.

Elder Okafor, the district leader, came down from Klamath Falls on the twenty-eighth to work a day's exchange. He was from Houston and missed very little. He rode with Bowman through three appointments and a flat tire, and at four in the afternoon, parked outside the Malin post office, he turned around in the seat.

Bowman. What is the matter with you? You've gone yellow. I mean it, look in the mirror, you're the color of a legal pad.

Elder Bowman looked at the dash for a while.

I'm not happy out here anymore, he said. *I think I want to go home.*

Okafor did not argue. He called Elder Pappas, who said *yeah* three times in a tired voice, and then he called the zone leaders, and the zone leaders called Eugene. In the morning the four of them were on Highway 97 before it was light, with the lake on the left gone to mudflat and Bowman in the back seat, and over Willamette Pass and down through the big firs to the valley, three and a half hours, hardly a word.

IV. The Mission Home

Eugene · the next morning

President Taufa had taught wood and metal shop at a high school in West Valley City, Utah, for thirty-one years before he was called to Oregon. He was a broad grey man of sixty-two who was missing the first joint of his left ring finger, which he said was the only thing a table saw ever taught him that he had not already known. He had been born in Nuku'alofa and brought to Salt Lake at nine. The elders said of him that he could sit through a whole interview and say eleven words, and you would walk out having confessed things you had not known you had done.

He had the other three wait in the front room. Sister Taufa gave them orange juice. The door of the office was left open, as it always was.

Elder Bowman. They tell me you want to go home. Is that true?

Yes, President.

The president nodded slowly.

Your brother served here. People in Klamath say Bowman and it means something. You came out in the same church, with the same book, under the same call. You could have had them saying, the little one, he was the best we ever had. And you are going to let them say he went home in his tenth month, trunky. That is a serious thing you are doing to yourself. I want you to hear me say so. He let it sit. *Now. Why?*

There's a woman. Where we get our water. Bowman's ears were burning. *Nothing happened, President. We never went in the house. She just, she said some things. She talks to me.*

I didn't ask you if something happened.

No sir.

It isn't strange, the president said. *That she talks. Or that you listen.* He had his scriptures on the desk, the old triple with the cover gone soft, and he put his hand on them and did not open them. *I am not going to read you Alma thirty-nine. You know what's in it. You haven't gone anywhere and I don't know that woman. I am going to tell you a story my father told me before every stake dance from the time I was fourteen. He was a deckhand on the*

copra boats when he was young. He had it from a ship's cook who came from Calcutta. That is all I know about where it's from.

He raised his voice a little, toward the front room. *You elders may as well hear it too.*

V. The Archer

As the cook told it

THERE WAS A YOUNG MAN ONCE, HE SAID, IN A COUNTRY WITH tigers in it, who was called the Little Archer. He had gone to the far side of that country to learn from the best teacher there was, and he learned so well that the teacher gave him his own daughter to marry. So he took his wife and his bow and started home.

At the mouth of a forest fifty bandits came out at them. The Little Archer had fifty arrows. He shot fifty times and fifty bandits lay down in the road. The fifty-first was their chief, and the quiver was empty. The archer threw down his bow and took hold of the chief with his hands and put him on his back in the dust and knelt on him, and called over his shoulder, *Wife, bring me my sword.*

She came with it. And she looked down at the bandit lying there, with his hair in his eyes, and he looked up at her. It took as long as it takes to say it. She put the hilt of the sword into the bandit's hand.

The best shot in that whole country, said President Taufa. *My father would stop there and look at us. Dead of one look. It wasn't even his.*

The bandit took the woman and went on. But as he walked he thought, She did that to a husband she had known for years, for me, whom she has known an hour. When she sees the next man, what will she do to me? They came to a river. *Give me your gold,* he said, *your bracelets and the rest. I'll carry it over first so it won't be lost, and come back for you.* She gave it to him. He waded across and went up the far bank and kept walking.

She called after him. *You have everything I own. Come back. Come back for me now.*

He called from the trees: *You traded the one you knew for one you didn't. You traded the sure thing for the thing that wasn't. You would trade me next. I am going a long way from here.*

So she sat down on the near bank in a thicket, with nothing. And while she sat there a jackal came along the shore with a piece of meat in his mouth. A fish jumped in the shallows. The jackal dropped the meat and went for the fish, and the fish went under, and a bird came down and took the meat and flew off with it. The jackal stood there in the water looking first one way and then the other.

The woman laughed out loud.

Who is that laughing in the bushes? said the jackal. *I don't hear any drum. I don't see any dancing. This is a strange place to be so cheerful.*

You fool, she said. *You had meat and you wanted fish, and now look at you.*

It is easy to see the other fellow's mistake, said the jackal. *You had a husband and you wanted a lover. Where are they? I think you will be sitting here a while.*

She stopped laughing. *You are right, jackal. I will go home, as far as it is, and find a husband, and do whatever he says.*

A person who walks off with the clay plate, said the jackal, *will walk off with the brass one. You'll do it again.* And he went up the bank.

• • •

Nobody in the front room said anything. Then Elder Pappas said, mostly to himself, *My great-grandpa had one like that. He was on a section gang at Wishram. It was a fox, though, and two otters, and a salmon. The fox got the middle.*

It gets around, said the president.

So she's the wife, Elder Bowman said. He was angry and did not know at whom. *That's what you're telling me. Tess is the wife with the sword.*

The cook always ended it the same way, my father said. He would point. The archer, that was you. The woman, that was her. And the jackal that shamed her, that was me. My father ended it that way too. I told it that way for thirty years. President Taufa turned the stump of his finger over and looked at it. *Then one night my wife asked me which one in that story has something good*

in his mouth and opens it for a thing that jumped. I have told it more carefully since. I don't know that young woman, Elder. I know you. You have been walking up the shore for nine months carrying something. Tell me what you have been looking at.

The porch, Bowman said, after a while. *About eight o'clock.*

For how long?

All day. All night.

That's how it is done. He opened the book now, and did not have to look for the place. *It is never a chain at the start. Nobody would stand still for a chain. It is a glass of water. Then a plate. Then a chair.*

> *yea, and he leadeth them by the neck with a flaxen cord, until he bindeth them with his strong cords forever.*
>
> *— 2 Nephi 26:22*

Flax is a soft thing. You could break one thread of it with your little finger. So you don't. You think about her, and that is a thread. You think about her again, that is two. You shave twice. You go over it in the night and make it a little prettier each time, and every time you go over it you have laid on one more, and by August it would hold a bull. She did not tie that on you. She doesn't know it's there. You plaited it yourself, lying on your back.

Bowman said nothing.

I taught shop. A boy brings me a board, he loves that board, it's got a figure in it like a flame. I say, turn it over. Look at the end grain. Look at the knot that's going to fall out, and the pitch pocket, and where it's cupped. I'm not telling him it is a bad board. I'm telling him he hasn't looked at it yet. He has looked at one face of it in good light. He closed the book on his finger. *You have been looking at one hour of that place, in the shade, with a plate in front of you. When the thought comes, don't feed it and don't wrestle it. Let it go quiet. Then go and look at the rest. Look at every part of it that is not eight o'clock on the porch, and keep looking until it is as plain to you as a board with the bark on. A man who will do that, and likes the quiet better than the picture, can take the whole rope off over his head.*

He turned back toward the front of the book.

> *Awake, my sons; put on the armor of righteousness. Shake off the chains with which ye are bound, and come forth out of obscurity, and arise from the dust.*
>
> *— 2 Nephi 1:23*

I could transfer you tonight, the president said. *Coos Bay. You would carry that porch to the ocean and polish it for fifteen months. No. Go back and get your water.*

VI. The Hydrant

Malin · August

They were back by dark. The next water day was a Saturday.

I'll take the hydrant, Elder Bowman said in the car, and Elder Pappas looked at him sideways and handed over the jugs.

It did stick. He leaned on it. From the pump house door a man could see the whole place, and for the first time since June he looked at it.

He saw the wheel line, which he knew. He saw that the green pivot was the only green thing to the horizon, and that it was green on a power bill. The meter on the pole was spinning like a coin. He saw a real estate sign lying face down in the weeds by the gate, with the post already on it, not yet stood up. Through the front room window there was a hospital bed, stripped, with the rails still raised, and a walker folded against it. There was a pair of a big man's irrigating boots on the porch by the door, set side by side, with six months of dust in them. He had walked past those boots eleven times.

And he saw her come around the house with a feed bucket, when she did not know anybody was looking. She was not coming across the yard with two glasses. She was a tired woman of twenty-seven, with her mouth set and one hand in the small of her back, who had buried her father in February and had been keeping two hundred and forty acres alive by herself in a drought ever since, and had cut her own hair. Her hands were

split at the knuckles from the alkali. She stopped by the boots and stood there a second and went on.

None of it was ugly. It was only all there. He looked for the woman he had been lying awake with, the one in the level light, and understood that he had made most of her himself, out of a wheel line and a porch and his own homesickness for a farm, and laid her over a real person the way you lay a decal on a window. He was ashamed. The feeling under the shame was better than he expected. He felt as if he had set down a pack.

The fourth jug ran over on his shoes.

She had the card table out. She fed them, and sat at the corner, and he was easy with her as he had not been once all summer, and asked about the sign.

Yeah, she said. *I list it Monday. There's a dairy out of Tulare wants the water right more than the dirt.* She turned her glass around on the oilcloth. *I go back to Portland in September. They held my job, can you believe that? I should have told you guys. I think I just liked having somebody on the porch. Dad sat right where you're sitting.*

Yes ma'am, said Elder Bowman.

He thought of it later, driving back with twenty gallons sloshing in the trunk. If he had gone home to Sugar City in August and driven back down in September in his father's pickup, with fifteen months of his word thrown in the ditch behind him, he would have come up the Malin road to a locked house and a dairy's sign. He saw himself standing in the yard, looking first one way and then the other. He laughed out loud. Elder Pappas asked what, and he said, *Meat and fish,* and Elder Pappas, who had been in the front room, did not need the rest.

• • •

The county tank came the second week of August, on a flatbed, and was set on cinder blocks beside the single-wide, and a truck filled it Tuesdays. They did not need the Havlik well after that.

They went up once more anyway. It was a Saturday in September, with Brother Dalton and his two boys and the elders quorum president and a stock trailer, eight men in all, and Sister Ruiz on her day off with a cooler.

They carried the hospital bed out through the front door and loaded forty years of Frank Havlik's shop. Elder Bowman fixed the wheel line, since he was there. It took him an hour and ten minutes. Tess shook hands with every one of them at the gate. She gave Elder Pappas the horseradish root, wrapped in a wet towel, to plant at his mother's, and she gave Elder Bowman the card with the koláče on it in her great-grandmother's hand, and told him to give it to whoever he married, and he said he would.

He served out his two years. In Klamath they say Bowman now and mean either one. The little one went on to Coos Bay after all, and Roseburg, and finished in Florence with a new elder from Tonga whom he trained to lean on things.

The morning the transfer call came, he and Elder Pappas rinsed out the four blue jugs for the last time and turned them upside down on the fence posts along Brother Dalton's lane to dry. They were still there when the car pulled out. From the road they looked like something that had been planted. The sun was coming up through them, and there was nothing in them at all.

Background

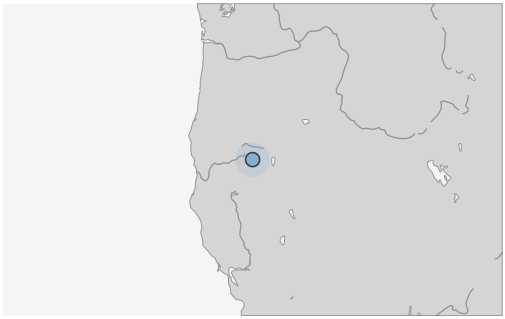
The verses

> *If a man is tossed about by doubts, full of strong passions, and yearning only for what is delightful, his thirst will grow more and more, and he will indeed make his fetters strong.*
>
> Dhammapada 349, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *If a man delights in quieting doubts, and, always reflecting, dwells on what is not delightful (the impurity of the body, &c.), he certainly will remove, nay, he will cut the fetter of Mara.*
>
> Dhammapada 350, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary a young monk takes his ticket-meal to the assembly hall, finds no water there, and goes to a house for some. The young woman of the house tells him to come to her and nowhere else when he needs water. In time she gives him gruel as well, then a seat and a meal, and sits near him and says how lonely the house is. He

grows discontented with the monk's life and so sallow that visiting monks ask what is wrong; his teachers bring him to the Buddha, who rebukes him and then tells a story of the past. A brilliant young archer, married to his teacher's daughter, kills fifty bandits with fifty arrows and pins their chief, but his wife, taken with the bandit at a glance, hands the bandit the sword. The bandit, reasoning that she would betray him as easily, strips her of her ornaments at a river and abandons her; the god Sakka, as a jackal who drops his meat to snatch at a fish and loses both, shames her. The Buddha identifies the monk as the archer, the woman as the wife and himself as the jackal, and speaks the two verses. Read the full commentary story; the tale within it is a version of the Jātaka of the Little Archer (no. 374). The old story lays the whole blame on the woman. The retelling keeps its events and its closing identification, and lets the teller have second thoughts.



Malin, Oregon

The Klamath Basin, 2022

The Klamath Project, begun in 1906, drained lakes and marshes on the Oregon–California line and irrigates some 200,000 acres from Upper Klamath Lake. Malin was settled on former lake bottom in September 1909 by sixty-five Bohemian families, who named it for a town near Kutná Hora; it is still known for horseradish. In the drought of 2021 the Bureau of Reclamation, bound to protect endangered sucker fish in the lake and salmon downstream, kept the project's main canal closed for the season, and the 2022 allocation was again a small fraction of normal. Farms that had deep wells pumped them, the water table fell, and shallow household wells failed across the county: 117 were formally reported dry by late July 2021, with officials suspecting more than 300, and reports kept coming through the winter. Families hauled water in five-gallon jugs. The state paid for storage tanks and trucked water for nearly 300 homes, and well drillers had waiting lists of up to a year.

Klamath Falls has had a Latter-day Saint congregation since 1930 and a stake since 1953; the area belongs to the Oregon Eugene Mission. Missionaries, most of them eighteen to twenty, serve in pairs for eighteen months or two years under a mission

president, are fed by local members, and do not enter a home where a lone woman is present without another adult. "Trunky" is their own word for a missionary whose mind has gone home ahead of him. The chapter the president declines to read, Alma 39, is a father's rebuke to a son who left his mission to follow a woman named Isabel. The people in this story, the ward and the Havlik farm are invented.

After the story of the wise archer Culla Dhanuggaha from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 349–350). The original. Scripture from the Book of Mormon. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

24.8

Sawn Ivory

> *Such dreams as pass through the portals of sawn ivory are deceitful, and bear tidings that are unfulfilled.*
> *— Odyssey 19.564–565*

So hat man mir's erzählt, in the Shiloh Valley.

I. The Lexicon

Shiloh Valley, St. Clair County, Illinois · October 1838

The Americans up at Shiloh called them the Latin farmers. They had come over in 'thirty-three and 'thirty-four, after the business at Frankfurt, doctors of law and of philosophy, a forester, two apothecaries, and they had bought prairie east of Belleville at a dollar and a quarter the acre and learned to plow it out of a book. It was said of them that they could curse an ox in Greek and that the ox was not improved by it.

Heinrich Lohr had taught Greek to the two upper forms of a Gymnasium in Hesse for eleven years. Here he had eighty acres, a log house with a loft, a yoke of oxen named for the sons of Atreus, and a boy. His wife had died in their second August, of the fever the Americans called the ague and dosed with Sappington's pills. The boy was called Rudolf and was eight years old.

Lohr did not know how to teach a child anything except the way he had taught the upper forms, so that was how the boy had it. At eight Rudolf had his German letters and his Latin ones and his Greek, and he knew the order of each, which stood before and which after. He could go into the big Passow, a lexicon that weighed as much as a churn, and come out with any word in the time it took a grown man to find his spectacles.

When the old gentlemen of the valley fell out over a reading they did not send for Lohr. They sent for the boy and the book.

He was a quiet child, and nothing much seemed to pull at him. At the store in Belleville he looked at the barley sugar with interest and did not ask for any. He went down to the spring after dark without a brand. The Methodists at the Shiloh meeting house, who were sorry for a child growing up with no church at all, said he was old for his years. His father said only that the boy slept well.

II. The Guests

A Thursday, toward midnight

Four of the old Giessen men were coming over from the Missouri side for the meeting of the Library Society, which the valley had founded two years before, and they were looked for on the Thursday by daylight. The ferry at St. Louis was held for wind. They came at midnight in a farm wagon, four gentlemen and one lantern, the oldest of them a former Hofrat who now raised hogs on the Femme Osage.

They had to be fed, and when they had been fed they had to sing, since they had not all been in one room in four years. They sang *Integer vitae* in four parts as they had sung it as students, Horace's ode to the man of clean life who needs no javelins. Then the Hofrat, who had the voice for it, read from the First Part of *Faust*, the scene in the study. The doctor has brought a black poodle home from his walk. He sits down to put the Gospel of John into German and cannot get past the first line, because he cannot decide what to do with the one word *logos*, and behind the stove the dog begins to grow.

> *Behind the stove still banned,*
> *See it, an elephant, expand!*
> *It fills the space entire,*
> *Mist-like melting, ever faster.*
>
> *— Goethe, Faust, Part I (the Study)*

Schwillt es wie ein Elefant, the Hofrat said again, and looked over the book at Lohr's own stove, a ten-plate stove hauled out from St. Louis and the only one in the valley, and the gentlemen laughed. Then, because the word had come up, he turned to the boy, who was still awake on the bench.

Elephas, young man. What is it?

Ivory, Herr Hofrat. In Homer it is only ever the tooth. They had the tooth a long time before they saw the animal.

And where in Homer?

The boy told him. Penelope, to the stranger, about the two gates.

> *Twain are the gates of shadowy dreams, the one is fashioned of horn and one of ivory. Such dreams as pass through the portals of sawn ivory are deceitful, and bear tidings that are unfulfilled. But the dreams that come forth through the gates of polished horn bring a true issue, whosoever of mortals beholds them.*
>
> *— Odyssey 19.562–567*

He said it in the Greek. Then, since his father had taught him never to leave a word standing by itself, he said what the poet was doing with it. *Elephas,* the ivory. *Elephairontai,* they cheat. *Keras,* the horn. *Krainousi,* they bring to pass. The cheat was already in the name of the thing it came through. He said it as he might have told a visitor which ox was the near one.

Lohr, said the Hofrat, *you have made a Gymnasium with one bench.* Lohr said it was past the boy's bedtime.

Then there was the matter of beds. The house had the one room with the stove, the loft over it where the boy slept, and a lean-to on the north side where Lohr kept his books and his own cot. The four gentlemen were given the loft and the boy's bed with it. Nobody told the boy. He had carried his blanket down the ladder before the Hofrat had his boots off. He looked about him, saw that every other place in the room was taken by a saddlebag or a doctor of philosophy, and lay down on the floor across the sill of his father's door, and went to sleep.

III. Behind the Stove

Toward morning

The Americans tell this part with the Devil in it. The Germans, who had left the Devil in Hesse with the Grand Duke's police, tell it with the thing out of the Hofrat's book. They agree on what it did.

It is said to have looked at the boy lying across the sill, and at the shut door behind him, and to have reasoned this way. The father is in there among his books. The son is out here, like a sore finger held away from the hand. Pinch the finger and the whole man will feel it.

The stove had burned down to a red line at the door. Behind it something that was not smoke began to gather. It swelled as it had been made to swell in the reading, gray, with a hide like a wet road, until its back was among the rafters and the loft boards lifted and creaked. It had a head the size of the meal chest. From the head a long gray arm came down, feeling, and went once around the boy's head where he lay, the way a man laps a rope around a post. Then it screamed. None of the four gentlemen in the loft had ever heard an elephant. They said afterward it was the cry the cranes make going over in November, if every crane in Illinois had been in the room.

The boy opened his eyes. He looked at what had hold of him for about as long as he would have looked at a word, and he did not put up his hands.

Lohr did not open his door. He spoke through it, in his schoolroom voice, which carried.

I know you. You are out of a book, and I have the book. If a hundred thousand of you stood in my kitchen you could not frighten my son. He is afraid of nothing, he wants nothing, he does a day's work, and he knows what he knows.

Then, as he might have given out lines for the form to construe, he gave the beginning of what they had sung at midnight, and after it the stanza of the wolf.

Integer vitae scelerisque purus
non eget Mauris iaculis neque arcu

A wolf, while roaming trouble-free
In Sabine wood, as fancy led me,
Unarm'd I sang my Lalage,
Beheld, and fled me.

— Horace, Odes I.22

The rest I will say in German, so that you cannot mistake it, said Lohr. *He wants nothing and he holds on to nothing. He knows words and what is inside them. He knows his letters, which stand before and which after. A person like that has come to the end of being frightened, and it is no small thing to be, at any age.*

It is told that the thing said, *The schoolmaster knows me,* in a voice like a flue. With that it had no more size than the smoke it had begun as. It thinned, and went out at the chinking, and the red line at the stove door was where it had been.

In the loft four old men who had argued God out of the universe at Giessen thirty years before lay on their backs and did not argue. The Hofrat said later that what he understood that night had nothing to do with devils.

• • •

In the morning the boy was asleep on the sill with the blanket over his ear. At breakfast the Hofrat asked him, as lightly as he could manage, whether he had been frightened in the night.

No, Herr Hofrat, said Rudolf. *It came through the ivory.*

He went and got the Passow down, as he did whenever the old gentlemen wanted a thing settled, and opened it on the table among the coffee cups and ran his finger down the column. There was *elephairomai,* I cheat. A little farther down stood *elephas.* He kept his finger there until the Hofrat had found his spectacles and seen which came first.

Background

The verses

> *He who has reached the consummation, who does not tremble, who is without thirst and without sin, he has broken all the thorns of life: this will be his last body.*
>
> Dhammapada 351, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *He who is without thirst and without affection, who understands the words and their interpretation, who knows the order of letters (those which are before and which are after), he has received his last body, he is called the great sage, the great man.*
>
> Dhammapada 352, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary several senior monks reach the Jetavana monastery late at night and are given the room of Rāhula, the Buddha's son, a novice who is said to be eight years old and already fully awakened. Seeing no other place, he lies down outside the door of the Buddha's own chamber. Māra, the tempter, reasons that the son lies there "as though his finger hurt him," and that to pinch the son is to pinch the father. He takes the form of a huge elephant, winds his trunk around the boy's head and trumpets. From inside, the Buddha tells him that a hundred thousand like him could not frighten his son, and speaks these verses. Māra says, "The ascetic Gotama knows me," and vanishes. Read the full commentary story, or about Rāhula.

Shiloh Valley, St. Clair County, Illinois

The Latin farmers, 1838

After students and young professionals failed to seize the Frankfurt guardhouse in April 1833 (the Frankfurter Wachensturm), a number of university-trained Germans left for America. One cluster bought farms in the Shiloh Valley east of Belleville, Illinois, where their neighbors named them the "Latin farmers" and the place the Latin Settlement. Many were freethinkers. In 1836 they began a German library society that grew into the Belleville Public Library, the oldest in the state. Others, the

Giessen Emigration Society of 1834, settled across the Mississippi in Missouri. Shiloh itself takes its name from a Methodist meeting house raised after an 1807 camp meeting. The Lohrs and their guests are invented.

Their books are real. In the study scene of Goethe's *Faust*, Part One (1808), Faust struggles to translate the Greek *logos* in the first line of John while the poodle he has brought home swells behind the stove "wie ein Elefant" and turns out to be Mephistopheles; the English here is Bayard Taylor's (1871). Penelope's speech on the gates of horn and ivory turns on a play between *elephas*, ivory, and *elephairomai*, to cheat, and between *keras*, horn, and *kraino*, to fulfil; the English is Butcher and Lang's (1879). In Homer *elephas* means only ivory; the animal comes into Greek later. Horace's ode *Integer vitae* was sung by German students everywhere in F. F. Flemming's four-part setting of 1811. Its opening says that the man whole in life and clear of wrong needs no Moorish javelins or bow; the English stanza is John Conington's (1863). Franz Passow's Greek and German lexicon was the standard one of the 1830s.

After the story of Māra and the elder Rāhula from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 351–352). The original. Scripture from Horace's Odes, in Latin and in John Conington's translation (1863), the Odyssey, translated by S. H. Butcher and A. Lang (1879), and Goethe's Faust, translated by Bayard Taylor (1871). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

24.9

Neither East nor West

> *What is to be done, O Moslems? for I do not recognise myself.*
> *I am neither Christian, nor Jew, nor Gabr, nor Moslem.*
> *— Rumi, Divani Shamsi Tabriz XXXI*

Chenin shenidam, on Route 60.

I. Seven Weeks

The upper Kanawha Valley, West Virginia · December 1979

There were forty-one Iranians at the college that fall, most of them in engineering, and after the fourth of November there was no way for any of them to be only a student. The Americans wanted to know whose side they were on. Somebody hung a bedsheet from the third floor of the men's dormitory with a thing about the Ayatollah painted on it, and in the cafeteria line a boy from Beckley asked Kamran every day, not unkindly, when he was going to let those people go. The Iranians wanted to know the same thing from one another, and were harder about it. Shahi, Tudeh, Mojahed, Hezbollahi. *Khatt-e ki hasti,* they said. Whose line are you. In Tehran the ones who had gone over the embassy wall called themselves the students who followed the Imam's line, and since then the word was in everything.

Kamran Yazdani kept his answer short. He was a junior in civil engineering, the son of a cloth merchant in the Yazd bazaar, and he believed more or less what his father believed. A man could no more work out the whole of religion for himself than do his own surgery, so he chose one learned man and followed him, and Kamran followed the same grand ayatollah his father did, whose book of rulings his mother had packed between his shirts. For the rest there was what was written. Before an ex-

amination he opened his mother's Hafez with his eyes shut and put his finger down. He had done it on the night of the fourth of November, and the verse had been one of the dark ones.

The money stopped in the middle of that month, when the President froze what Iran had in American banks and nothing more came through from home. By the middle of December every Iranian on a student visa was to have shown his papers to the immigration men, who came to the campus for two days with a folding table and a camera. Then a judge in Washington said the order was against the Constitution, and nobody knew yet whether that would stand. The dormitory closed for Christmas on the twenty-second. Kamran's lab partner, a boy named Randy Skaggs from up one of the creeks, said his daddy had room, and to come on.

The one nobody could place was Siavash. He was older than the rest of them, twenty-six, a mining man from Kerman who had been in the country since 'seventy-four and in everything. He had marched in Washington against the Shah in a paper mask. He had been a Marxist for two winters and after that had prayed in the front row, and each time he had gone all the way in, and each time he had come out the far side and said it was not there. He had shared a house on Fourth Avenue with five others as serious as he was. In the spring they told him he was a man who finished nothing, and they went down to the university at Huntington, the five of them in one car.

After the fourth of November he quit going out. He had a room over the hardware store with a radiator and a hot plate, and he was seen at the window. It was said that he sat. It was said that when the immigration men asked him at the folding table which group he belonged to, he said none, and that the officer wrote *none* and looked up at him, and stamped the paper. That was all anybody had. It went on seven weeks.

II. Whose Line

Route 60, below Smithers · December 23

Randy's father's place was up Peddler's Run, four miles of dirt off the highway, and Randy had said to wait at the mouth of the

RUN AND HE WOULD COME DOWN WITH THE TRUCK WHEN HE was done feeding. Kamran stood by the mailboxes with his suitcase. It was a gray noon, two days past the longest night of the year, which he had kept alone with a pomegranate from the Kroger and his mother's Hafez. The river was the color of a nickel. Coal trucks went by, and their wind moved his coat.

A man was walking toward him down the shoulder from the direction of town, carrying a gym bag. He walked like someone with a long way to go who was not thinking about the way. When he was near enough Kamran saw who it was, and for a moment did not believe it, because of the face.

Everybody Kamran knew that month had the same face. It was gray under the eyes from the news, and tight at the mouth from being asked. Siavash's was clear. The skin was clear and the eyes were quiet. He looked like somebody who had slept and eaten and owed no one, in a month when no Iranian in America slept.

Salaam, Kamran said. *Don't be tired. Your color has come back. You look well, brother, you look better than any of us. Where are you going on foot?*

Huntington.

That is seventy-five miles.

About that. There are five men there I have something to tell.

Kamran laughed, because it was the kind of thing Siavash had always said, and then stopped, because of the face. He asked what any of them would have asked.

Tell me, then. Whose line are you now? Who is it you follow? You have found a teacher. One of the grand ayatollahs, or some shaykh, somebody here. A man does not come to look like that by himself.

I have no line, Siavash said. *I follow no one. There is no teacher.* He said it without any heat. Then he began an old poem, the one that is sung as Mowlana's. Kamran knew it. When it came to the third line he heard it start the way every wall in Tehran had started that year. *Na sharqiyam, na gharbiyam.* Neither of the East nor of the West. He waited for the rest of the slogan, the Islamic Republic. The poem went the other way.

What is to be done, O Moslems? for I do not recognise myself.
I am neither Christian, nor Jew, nor Gabr, nor Moslem.
I am not of the East, nor of the West, nor of the land, nor of the sea;
I am not of Nature's mint, nor of the circling heavens.

— Rumi, Divani Shamsi Tabriz XXXI

That is his, and I am only borrowing the sound of it, Siavash said. *Here is mine. I have come through all of it. I see how it goes, every part, and none of it sticks to me now. I put everything down, Kamran. The Shah and the Imam and the Party and my own name for myself. The wanting went out, and when it went I was free. I found that out in a room over a hardware store, and nobody handed it to me. So whose name do you want me to give you?*

A coal truck went by. Kamran looked at him a while longer. He did not say yes and he did not say no. He tipped his head back, the way people do at home, and clicked his tongue once against his teeth. Then, because that was rude to a man with seventy-five miles in front of him, he said, *Inshallah. May it be so, brother.* He was shaking his head while he said it.

Randy's truck was coming down the run with its lights on. Siavash lifted the gym bag and nodded, as a man nods to someone he will see again or will not, and went on down the shoulder toward Charleston with the river on his left. Kamran got in the truck. It turned around at the mailboxes and went back up the dirt road.

III. Peddler's Run

That afternoon

RANDY'S FATHER RAN COONHOUNDS AND A TRAPLINE, AND HAD put in thirty years at the alloy plant between the two. There were hides drying on boards along the porch wall, and a buck from Thanksgiving week cut and wrapped in the freezer on the back porch, and four Walker hounds that came out from under the house and sang at the suitcase. Mr. Skaggs shook Kamran's hand and asked was he the Iranian. Kamran said he was. Mr. Skaggs said well, he didn't reckon Kamran had took anybody hostage personally, and to come in out of the cold, there were beans.

A girl was splitting kindling by the smokehouse, Randy's sister, home from nursing school. She did not look up yet.

At the supper table Kamran opened his mouth twice to tell about the man on the highway, and could not find where it began. Later, in the room they gave him, he took his mother's Hafez out of the suitcase and held it shut for some time with his finger along the edge of the pages. Then he put it back between the shirts without opening it. From the window he could see a little of the highway at the mouth of the run, where the lights of the trucks went by, heading down the valley.

Background

The verse

> *'I have conquered all, I know all, in all conditions of life I am free from taint; I have left all, and through the destruction of thirst I am free; having learnt myself, whom shall I teach?'*
>
> Dhammapada 353, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the Buddha, newly awakened, has spent seven weeks near the tree and sets out on foot for Benares, eighteen leagues off, to teach five former companions. On the road he meets Upaka, a follower of the Ājīvikas, a rival school of ascetics remembered for teaching that everything is settled by fate. Upaka admires his calm senses and clear complexion and asks in whose name he has gone forth, who his teacher is and whose doctrine he holds. The Buddha answers that he has no teacher, and speaks this verse. Upaka neither approves nor disapproves; in the older telling he says only, "It may be so, friend." Shaking his head, he takes a side path and goes to the house of a hunter. Read the full commentary story. Later tradition has him marry the hunter's daughter and, years afterward, come back.

Upper Kanawha Valley, West Virginia

The winter of 1979

On November 4, 1979, a group calling itself the Muslim Student Followers of the Imam's Line seized the American embassy in Tehran and began the hostage crisis. *Khatt*, line, became the word for a person's politics, and the revolution's slogan was "Neither East nor West, Islamic Republic." More than fifty thousand Iranians were then studying in the United States, many at small colleges. President Carter ordered them to report to immigration officers or face deportation, and on November 14 froze Iranian assets in American banks by Executive Order 12170, which cut many students off from money sent from home. A federal judge held the reporting order unconstitutional on December 11, and an appeals court reversed her on December 27 (*Narenji v. Civiletti*). In about two months 54,486 Iranians were interviewed; several hundred were eventually deported. The college, Kamran, Siavash and the Skaggs family are invented. U.S. Route 60, the old Midland Trail, follows the Kanawha River down to Charleston and runs on to Huntington.

Kamran's religion is the ordinary practice of Twelver Shia Muslims, each of whom follows the rulings of a living senior jurist, a marja'; the practice is called taqlid. Opening the poems of Hafez at random for an omen is an old Iranian custom, kept especially on Yalda, the longest night of the year, with pomegranates. The poem is number XXXI in R. A. Nicholson's *Selected Poems from the Divani Shamsi Tabriz* (1898), an early English selection of Rumi's lyrics. It has long been sung as his, though scholars have not found it in the oldest manuscripts of his Divan, and it may be by a later hand.

After the story of the Ājīvaka Upaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 353). The original. Scripture from Selected Poems from the Divani Shamsi Tabriz, translated by R. A. Nicholson (1898). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

24.10

Laid Over

> *What is truth? said jesting Pilate, and would not stay for an answer.*
> *— Francis Bacon, "Of Truth"*

As it was set down in the book, at the end of the Reeds Lake line.

I. Minutes of the First Meeting

East Grand Rapids, Michigan · Thursday, October 6, 1898

The Thursday Club met at the residence of Mrs. Josiah Orcutt on the lake road at half past two o'clock, twenty-nine members present, the afternoon fair and the steamer still running.

The constitution was read a second time and adopted. Article Three, limiting the membership to thirty-three, was debated and kept, on the ground stated by Mrs. Orcutt that thirty-three is the number of ladies who can be seated in one parlor if the piano bench is used. The village had already begun to call the club the Thirty-Three, and the club did not object.

Mrs. Lyman Hale read a paper on Sir Edwin Arnold's *The Light of Asia*, which she had borrowed from the Ladies' Literary Club downtown and must return Saturday. The paper was much admired, especially the passage on the young prince seeing the old man by the road, which Mrs. Hale read twice.

In the discussion Mrs. Orcutt observed that the club, and every club she had ever belonged to, talked a great deal and settled nothing. She moved that four questions be set for the season and answered by the annual meeting in May, so that the club might for once have something to

show. The questions were proposed from the floor, amended, and adopted as follows:

First. Which is the best of all gifts?
Second. Which is the best of all tastes?
Third. Which is the best of all pleasures?
Fourth. Why should the ending of desire, which Mrs. Hale's paper commends, be called the highest thing of all, when it is desire that makes the world go round?

The fourth was Mrs. Van Ess's, and she said she meant it.

Discussion was spirited. Mrs. Van Ess held that the best gift is a child. Mrs. Kuiper held that it is health. Mrs. Hale said the best taste is the first strawberry of June eaten in the patch, and several members agreed, and Mrs. Orcutt said that was a pleasure and not a taste, and it was not settled which. The hour being late, the chair ruled that the questions be taken up again at the next meeting.

Refreshments: tea, sliced tongue, a jelly roll. Adjourned at a quarter to five, to catch the car.
Clara M. Pell, Secretary

II. Laid Over

From the minutes · 1899–1909

May 25, 1899. Annual meeting. The four questions, not having been settled, were laid over to the autumn. Mrs. Orcutt said it was no disgrace. The Greeks had not settled them either.Laid over.

November 2, 1899. Each member reported the answers given at her own supper table. Mr. Orcutt: the best gift is a receipted bill. Mr. Van Ess: the best taste is beefsteak and the best pleasure is not being asked questions at supper. The secretary's husband, Mr. Walter Pell, said he would think about it, and has said so since. The answers of the hired girls were also reported, and were on the whole better.Laid over.

March 1900. The questions were written out and sent to the column of questions answered in the *Herald*. Reply pasted in below: *The Herald does not undertake questions of opinion.*Laid over.

August 1901. Mrs. Hale and Mrs. Kuiper, summering at the Bay View assembly, put the four questions to the lecturer after his afternoon address. He answered for an hour and fifty minutes. On the steamer home the two members could not agree on what he had said, and in the end neither could tell the other.Laid over.

January 1902. Mrs. Orcutt died on the ninth, at seventy-four. The club attended in a body. At her request her chair went to Mrs. Hendrik Kuiper's sister, so that the membership stays thirty-three. Among her papers was a slip in her hand: *Second question. Bread, I think. But I could not say why.*Laid over.

July 1903. The new figure-eight railway opened at Ramona. Mrs. Van Ess's boys rode it eleven times and reported, on the third question, that the best pleasure is the first drop and the worst is the eleventh. Noted for the record.Laid over.

1904–1905. Letters were sent to the women's clubs of Kalamazoo, Saginaw, Muskegon, Petoskey and Ann Arbor. Kalamazoo did not answer. Ann Arbor sent a reading list. Saginaw sent the four questions back to us in its own secretary's hand, under the words, *We have wondered also.*Laid over.

1906. At the summer furniture market the husbands of members put the questions to buyers from Boston, Atlanta, Denver, Los Angeles and London, England, who carried them home again on the trains, so that by the end of the year the questions had been asked, the secretary believes, in every state but two. A buyer in Omaha wrote at Christmas to ask whether we had settled it yet, as his wife wished to know.Laid over.

1907. The ministers of six churches were asked. One preached on the first question for three Sundays. One said the fourth question was heathen. One said he had wondered it since seminary and would be grateful to be told.Laid over.

March 1908. Not minuted at the time. The secretary's husband, Mr. Walter Pell, died on the eleventh of pneumonia, having thought about it nine years. The secretary has wished since that the questions had been answered while he could hear. This is entered out of its order and the club may strike it.Laid over.

May 1909. By the secretary's count the four questions have now been put to four hundred and twelve persons by name, not counting buyers' wives or the people of Saginaw. Ruth Hale, who was in her cradle at the first meeting, is ten, and asked at supper why grown people should want to know. The club has no answer to that either.Laid over.

III. Special Meeting

The village schoolhouse · Thursday, July 14, 1910

A SPECIAL MEETING OF THE CLUB WAS HELD JOINTLY WITH THE four trustees of the village, at the club's request, since by this date the questions were no longer the club's alone. The whole village had taken them up. The boys at the Ramona boat livery put them to strangers for a joke, and two of the strangers had come back the next Sunday to ask whether there was an answer yet. The schoolroom was full and people stood at the windows.

Each trustee was asked in turn.

Mr. Bostwick, who has the ice-houses on the west shore and knows the lake as well as any man living, said he did not know.

Mr. Kellogg, who leads the band in the pavilion at Ramona and has played to more people than live in the county, said he did not know.

Mr. Dykstra, who sells bedroom suites at the market to half the country, said he did not know, and that his grandmother in Zeeland would have known, but she was dead.

Mr. Hunt, of the bank on Wealthy Street, said he did not know either. He moved that the questions be referred to Mr. Elias Sackett, division superintendent of the street railway, on the ground that Sackett knew everything.

The motion was carried. Mr. Sackett was sent for at the car house and came in his shirtsleeves. He has been with the line since the steam dummy and laid the rails on Wealthy Street himself in 1892. He reads every conductor's trip sheet. It is said he knows the faces of a thousand riders and the stop each one gets off at, and that when a man is puzzled on the line about anything, a rule or a timetable or a debt, Sackett has the answer before the question is finished.

The four questions were read to him. He stood with his cap in his hands a long while.

He said he did not know. He said there was one person on his lines who did. Mrs. Hendrika Brink, who has taken the first car across the river every morning for twenty-two years, never misses, sits on the left, and gets down on the West Side at the free kindergarten.

Asked by the chair where Mrs. Brink was to be found that evening, he said: at the kindergarten. In market week the hotel laundries work late and the creche keeps the babies until their mothers come.

Mrs. Van Ess moved that the meeting go there at once. Carried, without a voice against. Mr. Sackett went to the telephone in the hall and asked the car house for a car.

C. M. P.

IV. The Car

Wealthy Street to the West Side · the same night

ENTERED BY THE SECRETARY AT THE REQUEST OF THE CLUB, which wished an account in full and not in minutes.

It was one of the open summer cars, with the benches straight across and no sides, and Mr. Sackett had every lamp in it lit. When it came round the loop at the lake it lit up the water as far as the steamer dock. Thirty-one of the thirty-three were aboard. The four trustees were aboard. Mr. Kellogg's cornet player came with his cornet and did not play it. The livery boys rode on the step, and husbands, and the Van Ess boys, and people none of us knew who had stood at the schoolhouse windows,

and Mr. Sackett rode on the front platform beside the motorman with his cap on.

We went in along Wealthy Street at a quarter to ten. People came out on their porches as we passed, because no car runs that line lit up like that at night, and I suppose we looked like something going to a fire or a wedding. Some of them called out to ask where. Mrs. Hale called back, *To get it answered,* and they did not know what she meant, but two men left a porch and ran and caught the step.

Down the hill into the city the stores were dark. On the bridge over the Grand River the lamps of the car lay in the water on both sides and went along with us. I had not been across to the West Side after dark in my life. It is small houses close together, and churches with two towers, and the chimneys of the factories where Mr. Dykstra's bedroom suites are made, and the names on the stores are Dutch and Polish. Women in the doorways held up babies to see the car.

The kindergarten is a frame storefront with the shades half down and a sign painted on the glass. There was one gas lamp lit inside. We got down, all of us, and stood in the street, and Mr. Sackett went to the door and took off his cap and knocked.

Mrs. Brink is small, past sixty, with white hair parted in the middle, and she wore a gray dress and a work apron. She had a boy on her lap of about three, in his stocking feet, his face swollen from crying. On the low tables behind her were the little boxes of the kindergarten gifts, all put away, and on the wall the children's paper weavings in rows. She looked past Mr. Sackett at the car with every lamp burning and at the fifty or sixty people in the street, and she did not get up, because of the boy.

Mr. Sackett, she said. *Why have you brought the whole East Side?*

He told her. He said these people had had four questions for twelve years and had asked them of everybody they could reach, and had come to the end of everybody, and that he had told them there was nobody on his lines who could make it plain except her.

She asked to hear them. Mrs. Van Ess, who had them by heart, said them through from the doorway.

Mrs. Brink did not take long. She said it the way you would tell somebody where the coats were.

The best gift is a true thing, given so the one you give it to can take it.

The best taste is the taste of it when it's taken. You can see it in the face.

The best pleasure is the same. There is only the one, it has three names.

And the end of wanting is the highest because the wanting is all the hurt there is. Take the wanting away and see what's left to hurt.

Mrs. Kuiper said, from behind me, that was easy to say.

Mrs. Brink said yes, it was. Then she showed us, though I do not think she meant to show us anything; she was only going on with what she had been doing before we came. The boy's name was Józef. His mother washed sheets in a hotel laundry and was late on account of the market, and he had been crying for her since six o'clock. Mrs. Brink had a red yarn ball on a string, the first of the gifts, the one for the littlest ones. She swung it out on its string where he could see it, and said *Here.* Then she closed it in her hand. *Gone.* Then she opened her hand. *Here.*

She had been doing it, she said, for an hour. He had cried at *gone* every time.

Now she did it again, in front of all of us, and the boy watched her closed hand, and at *gone* he did not cry. He waited. He put his own hand on top of hers. When it opened he laughed out loud, a big sound for a person that size, and the people in the street who could not see what had happened laughed too, without knowing what at. She did it twice more. The third time he did not reach for it. He sat back against her apron and watched the ball go round on its string, and his face had in it what she had said, the taking and the taste, and I understood that I had seen it before, on my children, on Walter once when the doctor told him it was nothing, and had not known what I was seeing. Then the boy was asleep.

He doesn't want it now, Mrs. Brink said. *Look at him. He found out a true thing tonight. It comes back, or it doesn't, and either way you are still sitting here.*

Nobody said anything. Mr. Sackett was standing in the door with his cap against his chest, and he began to say something under his breath, and then said it out, not loud.

> *... truth, which only doth judge itself, teacheth that the inquiry of truth, which is the love-making, or wooing of it, the knowledge of truth, which is the presence of it, and the belief of truth, which is the enjoying of it, is the sovereign good of human nature.*
>
> *Certainly, it is heaven upon earth, to have a man's mind move in charity, rest in providence, and turn upon the poles of truth.*
>
> *— Francis Bacon, "Of Truth"*

Bacon, he said. *I had that by heart at the Union School in 1868. I have said it to myself on the cars for forty years. I never knew what it was for.*

Then the mother came running up the street from Bridge Street in her laundry apron, frightened half to death by the car and the crowd at the door, and the people stood back for her, and Mrs. Brink handed her the boy asleep, and she went home with him without asking any of us anything.

Mr. Lutz the conductor counts passengers for the company, and he counted eighty-four of us going back. As far as the secretary knows, every one of the eighty-four went home with it. Nobody talked on the bridge. The cornet player did not play. At the loop Mrs. Hale got down and said only, *Well,* and went up to her house, and I heard her laughing on her porch in the dark.

V. Good Morning to All

The West Side · 1910–1935

ONE THING MORE HAPPENED THAT NIGHT, WHICH THE SECRETary did not see and had from Mr. Sackett.

When the rest of us were back on the car he stayed on Mrs. Brink's step. He said to her, *If that is the best gift, you have been giving it over here twenty-two years, and the whole East Side, and me on my own car every morning, have never had any of it. The next time you give it, let us have a share.*

She said that every morning at nine her children stood up at their tables and sang, and she showed him the place in the book.

> *Good-morning to you, Good-morning to you, Good-morning dear children, Good-morning to all.*
>
> *— Mildred J. Hill and Patty S. Hill, "Good-Morning to All," Song Stories for the Kindergarten*

All is all, she said. *I never thought to tell them so. From tomorrow I will. And when they say the blessing at noon I will tell them that one goes to everybody too, the cars and the bridge and your side of the river. Even the thank-you. Everything they say in that room.*

So the next morning Mr. Sackett issued an order, which is pasted in below, that every car on the Bridge Street line passing the kindergarten at nine o'clock on a school day should ring its gong twice. Most of the motormen did not know why and did it anyway. The children did not know why the cars rang and stood up and sang to all.

July 21, 1910. Regular meeting. The secretary read the account of the 14th, which was accepted. Moved by Mrs. Van Ess that the four questions be removed from the order of business as answered. Carried. Mrs. Kuiper asked that it be recorded she still found it easy to say. So recorded. Refreshments: bread and butter.Answered. See Mrs. Brink.

• • •

Added in a later hand, 1935. Mrs. Hendrika Brink died in 1922 and is buried with the Zeeland people. Mr. Sackett outlived her by four years. Mrs. Pell, who kept this book for twenty-six years, died in 1931, and the secretary is now Ruth Hale Dekker, who was in her cradle at the first meeting. The kindergarten is still kept, and the children still stand at nine, and the cars rang twice at that corner every school morning until this year, when the city gave up its streetcars. This morning at nine the children stood and sang to all, and nobody rang, and they sang it anyway. The rails are still in Bridge Street. The sprinkler wagon had gone by, and they were wet, and shone both ways.

Background

The verse

> *The gift of the law exceeds all gifts; the sweetness of the law exceeds all sweetness; the delight in the law exceeds all delights; the extinction of thirst overcomes all pain.*
>
> Dhammapada 354, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three raise four questions: which gift is best, which flavor, which delight, and why the destruction of craving is called supreme. For twelve years they ask one another across ten thousand worlds, then go to the Four Great Kings, who send them to Sakka, lord of the gods, who knows at once the answer to whatever a thousand beings have pondered. Sakka says only a Buddha can answer, and leads the whole throng by night to Jetavana, lighting up the grove. The Buddha answers: the gift, taste and delight of the Dhamma are best, and the end of craving ends all suffering. Sakka then asks that the merit of the teaching be shared with the gods, and the Buddha tells the monks that from then on the merit of every sermon, and even of words of thanksgiving, is to be given to all beings. Read the full commentary story, or about Sakka.

East Grand Rapids, Michigan

Grand Rapids, 1898-1910

A streetcar line out to Reeds Lake opened in 1875 with horse cars, ran for years behind a steam engine the town called the dummy, and was electrified in the early 1890s. The railway company ran an amusement park at the lake, Ramona Park, with a theater pavilion, steamboats, and a figure-eight coaster from 1903, to fill the cars on summer evenings. East Grand Rapids incorporated as a village in 1891 and had 466 people in 1900 and 800 in 1910, a lake resort turning into a suburb along the line. The city across the river was the Furniture City, whose twice-yearly furniture market brought buyers from all over the country; Dutch and Polish immigrants were among the many who found work in its furniture factories, and its West Side was home to

working-class immigrant families, the Polish parish of St. Adalbert among its churches. Grand Rapids gave up its streetcars in 1935. The Thursday Club, its members, Mr. Sackett and Mrs. Brink are invented.

The kindergarten movement, after Friedrich Froebel, reached Grand Rapids early: an 1891 county history records the Misses Bacon's kindergarten training school, which ran for about twelve years before 1882, and a free kindergarten and creche opened in 1888 by a circle of the King's Daughters, where working mothers left their babies and fetched them in the evening (Baxter's history of Grand Rapids). Froebel's first gift is a set of soft yarn balls on strings. "Good-Morning to All," by the Louisville kindergarten teachers Mildred and Patty Hill, appeared in their *Song Stories for the Kindergarten* (1893); the words are quoted here from a later edition, where it is marked "To be sung standing." Its tune is the one later sung as "Happy Birthday." Bacon's "Of Truth" opens his *Essays* (1625). Edwin Arnold's *The Light of Asia* (1879) was read in parlors and women's clubs across the country.

After the story of Sakka's question from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 354). The original. Scripture from Francis Bacon's "Of Truth" and Mildred and Patty Hill's "Good-Morning to All." Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24.11

Laurel Hell

> *Thou fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee: then whose shall those things be, which thou hast provided?*
> *— Luke 12:20*

Here's how I heard tell of it, at the mouth of Bearpen.

I. The Jars

Bearpen Fork of the North Fork of the Kentucky River · August 1899

Jehu Carnes was found dead on the fourth of July, sitting at his own table with his spoon in his hand and a bowl of mush in front of him gone hard as plaster. He was seventy-nine years old. He had lived alone at the head of Bearpen for fifteen years, since his wife died, and before that he had lived there with her and no children for twenty-seven. He had no brother living and no sister and no nephew and no niece, and when the circuit clerk went through the books at the county seat to see who his heirs might be, there was not one, not a cousin, not anybody, back to the Revolution.

They buried him on the point above the house beside his wife. The preacher, an Old Regular Baptist from over on Carr Fork who had known him sixty years, stood at the head of the grave with his hat in his hand and lined out a hymn, and the few who came sang it back to him the long slow way, and afterward the preacher opened his Bible to the twelfth of Luke and read one verse and closed it again.

> *But God said unto him, Thou fool, this night thy soul shall be required of thee: then whose shall those things be, which thou hast provided?*
> *— Luke 12:20*

Nobody on Bearpen thought that was unkind. They knew what he meant. Everybody on the creek had always known Jehu Carnes was rich. They just did not know how rich, and they had never seen a dollar of it.

In August the escheater came up the creek. He was a lawyer from the county seat named Cyrus Webb, a careful heavy man in a linen duster, and the Auditor of Public Accounts in Frankfort had appointed him to look after property in that county that fell to the Commonwealth when a man died and left no one to have it. He had a paper from the circuit court and two deputies and a wagon, and he had three men from the creek hired at a dollar a day with mattocks and spades.

It took them seven days.

They found the first jar under the hearthstone, a half-gallon fruit jar with a zinc lid, packed so full of gold that the coins did not rattle when they shook it. Twenty-dollar pieces, double eagles, with the eagle on the back. They found two more under the puncheons of the floor. They found one in the springhouse wall behind a loose rock, and one in the smokehouse in the ash pit, and one buried in the hog lot so deep the man with the mattock nearly quit. They found three in a hollow sycamore down by the creek, stuffed up inside it with rags, and one under each of the four bee gums, and the bees came out and stung everybody. They found greenbacks rolled in oilcloth in the rafters, gone soft and brown, and silver dollars in a lard can in the corn crib, and a leather poke of gold under the shuck mattress he died sleeping on.

Every evening Mr. Webb counted it at the dead man's table by a coal-oil lamp, with a deputy at the door with a shotgun, and wrote it in a ledger. On the seventh evening he added the columns twice and sat back and looked at the number for a long time. It came to forty-one thousand, three hundred and sixty dollars. There was not that much money, he thought, in every bank between there and Beattyville put together.

They hauled it down the creek in the wagon with the deputies walking on either side, and the whole creek came out on the porches to watch it go by.

II. How He Lived

The head of Bearpen

MR. WEBB HAD BEEN ASKING ABOUT HIM ALL WEEK WHILE THE men dug, and everybody on the creek had something to tell.

He had owned the best land on Bearpen, nine hundred acres of it, bottom and hillside and the high woods, and the biggest poplar timber anybody had ever seen. For forty years he had cut it and snaked it down to the creek with oxen, and every spring, when the snows melted and the log tide came, he had sent it down the North Fork in rafts, to Beattyville and on down the river to the sawmills at Frankfort, and come home with money. In the nineties a man from Pittsburgh had come through buying up the coal under people's land for next to nothing, and Jehu Carnes was the only one on the creek who made him pay ten times what the others got, and in gold. The tides had always come high for him. Other men's rafts broke up on the shoals and his came through. Other men's sons drowned breaking jams and his hired hands came home. Whatever he touched made money. He had never seemed to know what to do with it except dig a hole.

He lived in the same two-room log house he had built in 1846. He wore tow linen, the coarse stuff spun from flax waste that people had stopped wearing after the war, and in winter a coat made of a feed sack with holes cut for his arms. He ate mush made of cornmeal sweepings, the bran and grit from the bottom of the mill bin that the miller gave away for hogs, and he drank clabber gone sour, and that was all he ate, morning and night, for as long as anybody could remember. He drove a sled behind a blind mule because a wagon cost money. When it rained he held a leaf over his head off the umbrella tree that grew by his springhouse, a leaf as long as your arm, and walked to the store at the mouth of the creek that way, with the water running off the end of it.

The widow Hensley, who had kept house for him two days a week the last years, told Mr. Webb about the chicken. Once, the first year, feeling sorry for him, she had fried a chicken and made biscuits and gravy and brought it to his table on her own good platter, the blue one. He had

looked at the platter a long time. Then he stood up and said, *So that's what folks eat, is it. You come in my own house to make sport of me.* And he had run her out the door and down the path to the creek, throwing rocks and clods of dirt and the biscuits after her, and stood in his door when she was gone and said, to nobody, *Mush is what a man ought to eat.*

The storekeeper told the same thing about a coat. A drummer from Cincinnati had come through with good wool coats and Jehu had stood and looked at one for most of an hour and then thrown it in the road and walked off under his leaf. The miller told it about a buggy. It was always the same. He would look at the good thing for a long time, the way a hungry dog looks at a man with a stick, and then he would drive it off.

Mr. Webb wrote it all down. He had been a lawyer for twenty-two years and seen a great many kinds of men, and he did not understand this one. At noon on the eighth day, with the money gone down to the bank at the county seat and nothing left to do on Bearpen but sign his name, he walked down to the schoolhouse at the mouth of the creek to see Miss Orpha Day.

III. Noon

The Bearpen school · the dinner hour

THE BEARPEN SCHOOL WAS A LOG HOUSE WITH ONE DOOR AND one window and a stick-and-mud chimney, and a stove that smoked, and split-log benches with peg legs, and forty-three scholars in it from six years old to nineteen, sitting by size. The common school ran in the summer and fall in that country, from July until the roads got too bad to walk, and in the middle of the day the children took their dinner buckets out under the beech trees and ate cold cornbread and beans and played Anty-over across the roof.

Miss Orpha Day had taught it for forty years. She was sixty years old and had never married, and she had been to every meeting on the creek in her life and never once gone up to be saved, which the preachers held against her and the mothers did not. She was a thin straight woman with grey hair pulled back hard and spectacles she had bought in Lexington

the one time she went there. Everybody on Bearpen under the age of fifty had learned their letters from her, and some of their mothers had too. People went to her about things they did not take to the preacher or the doctor or the law. It was said on the creek that Miss Orpha knew things. Nobody knew how.

She was sitting on the doorsill with her own dinner bucket when Mr. Webb came down the path in his linen duster, mopping his neck, and she moved over and let him sit on the step below her.

Well, Mr. Webb, she said. *What are you doing out in the heat of the day?*

He told her. He told her about the jars and the bee gums and the sycamore, and the forty-one thousand dollars, and the mush and the clabber and the tow shirt and the leaf, and the widow Hensley running down the path with biscuits hitting her in the back.

I can't make it out, he said. *A man with that kind of money, eating hog feed and carrying a leaf for an umbrella. He could have had anything. Why would a man do that?*

Miss Orpha set her dinner bucket down on the sill beside her and looked out at the children under the beeches for a while.

I'll tell you, she said. *It goes back a ways.*

IV. The Walking Man

Bearpen · 1857

When Miss Orpha was a girl there was a man who walked the mountains. Everybody from the Big Sandy to the Cumberland knew him, and nobody knew where he came from. People called him Old Tagg. He did not preach and he did not peddle and he did not beg. He walked the ridges with a stick, winter and summer, in a long coat, and slept in barns and corn cribs where people let him, and if somebody set food in front of him he ate it and said *Thank ye* and walked on. Those were nearly the only words anybody ever heard him say. Children followed him a mile down the road just to be near him, and he let them. Dogs that bit everybody else lay down in the road when he passed. Old people said a house he had eaten in did well. Some said he had been a

PREACHER ONCE AND LOST HIS VOICE AND FOUND SOMETHING better. Some said he was the Wandering Jew. Miss Orpha said, sitting on the sill, that she had seen him twice as a girl and had never in her life seen anybody look so much as if he had come to the end of something.

In the fall of 1857 Old Tagg came up Bearpen and stopped at the Carnes place at dinnertime.

Jehu was thirty-seven then and newly married to Ruth Fields from over on Rockhouse, who was a good woman, everybody said so, a churchgoing woman who gave to anybody. Jehu was already close. He saw the old man standing at the gate and got up from the table and said over his shoulder to his wife, *Give the old man something,* and went out to the field.

Ruth Carnes stood in her kitchen and thought she had not heard that word in that man's mouth since the day she married him. *Give.* And she thought, Today I am going to give, the way I have wanted to. She brought Old Tagg into the house and sat him at the table and set before him the best of everything she had. She cut the ham that was meant for Christmas. She made biscuits with the white flour that came from the store. She opened the honey and the preserves and poured him sweet milk, and she fried a chicken, and she wrapped what he could not eat in a cloth for him to carry.

Jehu met him on the path going down, with the bundle. *Did you get anything, old man?* And he took the cloth and opened it and looked. There was the ham, and the white biscuits, and the chicken.

Miss Orpha said it was not that he took it back. He did not take it back. He tied the cloth up again and handed it to the old man, and Old Tagg said *Thank ye* and went on down the creek. But Jehu stood in the path and said, out loud, so that the boy who was hoeing for him that summer heard it and told it for the rest of his life: *That ought to have gone to my hands. A man that eats like that will work for you. That old man will eat it and lay down in somebody's barn and sleep. It's throwed away.*

Now listen to me, Miss Orpha said to Mr. Webb. *That dinner made him rich. Old folks always said a house Old Tagg ate in did well, and that house did better than any on the creek. The tides came high for him from that year on. You've seen what it came to. But what he said in the path, that it was throwed*

away, that went into him too. From that day he never could stand to see a good thing used. Not by anybody. Not by himself. He'd look at a chicken on a platter and see it throwed away. He had the money and he had the begrudging, both, and they came in the same door the same day.

V. Sang

The high woods above Bearpen · September 1859

Jehu had a younger brother named Elisha who owned the other half of the Carnes land, the lower half, the wide bottom at the forks and the best of the poplar. In the spring of 1859 Elisha drowned on the North Fork breaking a log jam at the head of a tide, and his wife had died two winters before of the lung fever, and he left one child, a boy named Davy, six years old.

The boy came to live with his uncle Jehu and aunt Ruth, and the circuit court made Jehu his guardian, and the land went into Jehu's keeping until the boy was grown.

Miss Orpha knew Davy Carnes. It was her first school, the summer she was twenty, in a smaller house than this one, and he was the youngest scholar in it, a towheaded boy who could already say the alphabet backwards and was proud of it. She said he was a talker. He went everywhere holding his uncle's finger, because his uncle was the biggest thing he had left, and as they went he talked. *That's my daddy's mule. That's my daddy's bottom. Them's my daddy's poplars, Uncle Jehu, ain't they. When I'm big I'm going to raft them to Frankfort.*

Jehu heard it every day. And he thought, Miss Orpha said: He talks like that now. When he's grown, what will there be left of mine?

In September, when the sang berries turn red and the whole creek goes up into the high woods to dig ginseng to sell to the buyers for the China trade, Jehu took Davy sang hunting. They went up past the last cleared ground into the coves under the ridge where the big laurel grows, the thickets so dense and so tangled and so high over your head that a man can get into them and never find his way out. Hunters had died in them. The mountain people called those places laurel hells. Jehu took the

boy to the edge of one, and there, under a laurel bush, he took him by the neck and killed him. Miss Orpha said it the way she said everything, plainly, looking out at the beeches. He broke him the way you would snap a radish. Then he threw the body as far as he could into the laurel, and walked home, and told Ruth the boy had wandered off from him digging sang and he could not find him.

The whole creek hunted for Davy Carnes for three weeks. Miss Orpha hunted. She let her school out and took the big scholars up into the coves with her and they hollered his name until they had no voices, and fired guns, and men went into the edges of the laurel on their bellies and came out torn and bleeding and did not find him. Jehu hunted harder than anybody. After three weeks they stopped. Children got lost in the laurel. It had happened before.

The lower half of the land went to Jehu. And Ruth Carnes, who had wanted children more than anything in the world, carried four babies in the twenty-five years after that and lost every one of them before its time, and buried them in a row on the point above the house, and died at forty-eight. Nobody ever told her anything. Miss Orpha said she thought Ruth knew anyway.

VI. Where He Is

The Bearpen school · noon

MR. WEBB HAD NOT SAID A WORD.

So that's your answer, Miss Orpha said. *The dinner Ruth gave got him his money. What he said in the path kept him from ever touching it. Every time he looked at a biscuit he saw it throwed away. And the boy took his children from him, and his name, and that's why it's going to Frankfort with you in a wagon. It's not the first time, either. You go back in your books, Mr. Webb, you'll find more than one on these creeks died with jars in the ground and nobody to dig them.*

And now? Mr. Webb said, and did not know why he asked it.

Miss Orpha took off her spectacles and wiped them on her apron.

The good's all used up, she said. *He used it up on gold. He never laid by any more. There's nothing holding him anywhere now. He's in the laurel, Mr. Webb. Further in than any man ever crawled. He's been in there since the fourth of July, and he can't find his way out, and nobody's hollering his name.*

Mr. Webb sat on the step for a long while. Under the beeches the children were playing Antny-over, throwing a yarn ball over the roof of the schoolhouse and yelling, and a boy of six or seven came running around the corner after it and stopped dead at the sight of the man in the linen duster and ran back.

Forty-one thousand dollars, Mr. Webb said at last. *And he never ate a decent meal. And he lived a mile up the road from this.* He looked at the schoolhouse behind him, at the stick chimney and the one window with paper over a broken pane and the smoke-black ceiling and the forty-three dinner buckets in a row along the wall. *He never gave you a dollar, did he. Not a stove. Not a book.*

Not a penny, Miss Orpha said.

Then she reached behind her for the Bible she read from every morning, because in those days the Bible was the first reader in every school on the creek, churched or unchurched, and she found the place without looking for it and read it to him on the step.

> *But they that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition. For the love of money is the root of all evil: which while some coveted after, they have erred from the faith, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.*
>
> *— 1 Timothy 6:9–10*

Drown men, Miss Orpha said, and closed the book. *That's the boy. Pierced themselves through. That's him.*

Then she stood up and rang the hand bell for the afternoon, and the children came in from the beeches, and Mr. Webb sat on the step and listened to forty-three voices through the wall saying the multiplication table in a single long chant, the way they learned it then, sixes and sevens

and eights, rising and falling, and found that he was crying, and did not know when he had started.

VII. The Laurel

The high woods · September 1899

In October a wagon came up Bearpen with an iron stove in it, and window glass, and a crate of new readers, and a slate for every child, and a bell for the roof. There was no note with it. Nobody on the creek had to ask who sent it. Some said Cyrus Webb had spent every cent of his fee on the Carnes estate to buy it, and some said more than that.

But before that, in the last week of September, when the sang berries were red, he came back up the creek with four men and axes and asked Miss Orpha to show them the way.

She took them up past the last cleared ground into the cove under the ridge. She had not been there in forty years. She went to it as straight as if she had been there the day before. The men cut into the laurel with their axes, and it was slow, the trunks twisted together like a rope and hard as iron, and they cut for most of a day, a tunnel a man could stand up in, with the cut laurel piled behind them.

At the end of the afternoon one of the men stopped cutting and called back.

He was lying where he had been thrown, very small, gone mostly back into the leaves after forty years, under the laurel, with one shoe still on. Miss Orpha knelt by him in the leaf mold. Mr. Webb said afterward that she did not cry. She said, *Well, Davy,* the way you would say it to a scholar who has come in late, and gathered him up into a clean meal sack, and one of the men carried him out.

They buried him on the point above the old Carnes house, though not in the row. They buried him across the point on the other side, under a big poplar that had somehow been missed in all those years of cutting, one of his daddy's poplars, where you could see the whole of Bearpen down to the forks. Miss Orpha read over him. All her scholars came, and stood in rows by size.

Coming down, the men stopped to look back. The tunnel they had cut into the laurel hell went in from the edge of the cove, dark and straight, the ends of the cut trunks showing white. Inside it the laurel had already started to close.

Background

The verse

> *Pleasures destroy the foolish, if they look not for the other shore; the foolish by his thirst for pleasures destroys himself, as if he were his own enemy.*
>
> Dhammapada 355, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a rich man of Sāvatthī called Aputtaka, "Childless," dies without an heir, and King Pasenadi of Kosala spends seven days carrying his wealth to the palace. At noon the king comes to the Buddha and describes how the man lived: he drove off servants who brought him fine food, clothes and carriages with sticks and clods of earth, ate broken-rice porridge with sour gruel, wore hemp, rode a broken-down chariot and held a parasol of leaves over his head. The Buddha explains. In a past life the man told his wife to give alms to a silent solitary sage, and she gave the best food in the house; meeting the sage on the road, he looked in the bowl and regretted it, saying his servants should have had it. He also killed his brother's only son in the forest for his inheritance. The gift made him rich; the regret kept him from enjoying anything; the murder left him childless through seven lives and sent him to hell, where, his merit spent, he is again. When the king laments that the man never used his wealth or gave it to a teacher living nearby, the Buddha speaks this verse. Read the full commentary story.

Bearpen Fork, Kentucky

Eastern Kentucky, 1899

In the 1890s the coal under the mountains of eastern Kentucky was being bought up, often cheaply and before any railroad reached it. The most famous buyer, John C. C. Mayo, was a schoolteacher from Paintsville who began buying mineral rights with his teaching salary, formed a land company in 1888, and later devised the broad form deed, which severed what lay under the ground from the surface and let the mineral owner take it by almost any means. Timber came out first. Logs were hauled to the creeks and floated down the forks of the Kentucky River on the spring floods, the "log tide," gathered into rafts at Beattyville and taken down to the sawmills at Frankfort, a trip of a week or more. In late summer families dug wild ginseng, "sang," for export to China; in recent decades most of the country's wild ginseng exports have come from the southern Appalachian states, especially Kentucky. The rhododendron and mountain laurel thickets of those coves are so dense that they are called laurel hells, because it is nearly impossible to get through one.

When a person died with no heirs at all, the property passed to the state by escheat, an old common-law rule that once sent a dead tenant's land back to the Crown. Kentucky's statutes of the period provided for escheaters, appointed by the state Auditor, who sued in the name of the Commonwealth in the circuit court of the county where the property lay. Jehu Carnes is buried by an Old Regular Baptist preacher, who lines out the hymn the way that church still does, reading each line for the congregation to sing back. Bearpen Fork, its school and everyone on it are invented.

After the story of the Childless Rich Man (Aputtaka) from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 355). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

24.12

Thirteen Kettles

> *And other fell on good ground, and did yield fruit that sprang up and increased.*
> *— Mark 4:8*

This is the way I got it, at Sheep Camp.

I. The Row of Fires

Dyea to Lake Bennett · August 1897 to March 1898

Anker Mikkelsen was a wholesale grocer of Tacoma, a Dane, fifty-six years old, a deacon of his Lutheran church and a careful man. In the eight weeks after the *Portland* came into Seattle with her ton of gold, he sold more beans, bacon, flour and evaporated potatoes than he had sold in the eight years before. The Canadians would let no man over the passes without a year's provisions, the better part of a ton, and every clerk and streetcar conductor on Puget Sound was buying his ton. By the end of August Mikkelsen had forty thousand dollars he had not had in June.

He could not sleep on it. He had looked at the men who bought. He had weighed out a year of beans for a consumptive bookkeeper, and for two boys from a hop farm who could not have been seventeen, and he had taken their money and wished them luck. He told his wife he was going north to give some of it back along the road it had come down.

He did it the way he did everything, with a plan and a ledger. The trail from tidewater at Dyea to the head of Lake Bennett, where the boats were built, was thirty-three miles, which the old Hudson's Bay men would have called twelve leagues, and it went over the Chilkoot Pass. Mikkelsen set a kettle at every place on it where men stopped. There was

one on the flats at Dyea, and one at Finnegan's Point by the toll bridge. There was one at Canyon City, and at Pleasant Camp, and at Sheep Camp under the mountain. There was one at the Stone House, and one at the Scales, where the loads were weighed again before the last climb. Over the summit, on the Queen's side, there were six more, at the Crater, at Happy Camp, at Long Lake and Deep Lake, at Lindeman and at Bennett. That made thirteen kettles. Each was a forty-gallon iron wash boiler on a stone hearth under a fly of canvas, with a hired man to keep the fire and a sign on a board. *MIKKELSEN. HOT SOUP & BREAD. NO CHARGE.*

The fires did not go out from the last week of August until spring. At night, from the Scales, a man could look back down the canyon and see four of them, one below the other, like lamps on a stair.

He moved up and down the line himself, in a Mackinaw coat, checking the fires. He kept the count in a black book. Each kettle man made a pencil stroke for every bowl, and Mikkelsen added the strokes on Saturday night, the way he had added the day-book in Tacoma. By New Year the figure was past thirty thousand. By the end of March it was sixty-one thousand, four hundred and some, which was nearly twice the number of people the last census had found in the whole District of Alaska.

Men ate his soup and went up. That was all anyone could say afterward about what became of it. They ate it standing, with the pack still on, looking over the rim of the bowl at the trail. Each man had his ton to move, forty or fifty trips on his own back from one cache to the next, and every hour he stood still he could see other men passing him toward the gold. They shoved in the line. Two partners from Ohio, who had come north closer than brothers, pulled knives on each other over a place at the Canyon City kettle. A man at Lindeman was found selling Mikkelsen's free bread at fifty cents the loaf. Three boilers were stolen that winter by men who wanted them to boil pitch for their boats. Men cursed the soup when it was thin. When it was thick they came through the line twice with their hats pulled down.

Mikkelsen did not hold it against them. He did not hold anything against anybody. He ladled when a kettle man was sick, and he never

looked up from the ladle to see whose bowl it was. A bowl came, and he filled it, and it made a stroke in the book.

II. The Spoon

The Scales · Saturday, April 2, 1898

It had snowed for five days. Then the wind went round to the south and blew warm, and the new snow on the mountain turned heavy and began to talk.

Isaac was a Chilkoot man, from the people who had owned that trail before there was any Dyea. His grandfathers had carried eulachon grease over it to trade with the people of the interior, and had let nobody else use it, not even their own cousins the Chilkats. He was thirty or so. He packed for wages. In the bad autumn, when the trail was mud and the stampeders were frantic, the packers had got as much as a dollar the pound to the summit. Now that the tramways were running, it was down to a nickel. Isaac carried a hundred and forty pounds at a trip with a strap across his forehead, and he could tell you what that came to.

He had brought one load up to the Scales that morning. It was his last. He sat on it to eat before he went down. He had a tin pail with what was left of his own dinner, beans cooked with a piece of salmon, and a spoon. He did not eat at Mikkelsen's kettle, which was thirty yards off with fifty men around it, pushing. Nobody had told him he could not. He did not like the way they ate.

Old Andrew Rudd came down off the Golden Stairs at about noon, with the mail sack.

Everybody on the Chilkoot knew Rudd, and nobody could have said what he was for. He had come into the country in 1886, ahead of all of them. He had taken gold out of the Fortymile and spent it, and taken out more and been robbed of it, and lost three toes and a partner, and somewhere on the Yukon ten years before Bonanza Creek he had lost the wanting too. Men said it had gone out of him like a tooth. Now he carried the mail between Dyea and Bennett for whatever the post office paid. He boarded at the widow Garrity's eating tent at Sheep Camp when he was

on that side. He owned what was on his back. In March the glare off the snow had taken his eyes for the third time, and this time they had not come back. He went up and down the Chilkoot with his hand on the guide rope and a red handkerchief tied over his face. On the days she could get away, the widow's girl walked him as far as the Stone House by a cord around her wrist.

He came along the rope past the kettle. He had not eaten since Lindeman. He stood at the edge of the crowd there with his bowl out, and men went around him on both sides.

Rudd, said Isaac.

The old man turned his handkerchief toward the voice and came over, feeling with his feet.

There was one spoonful in the pail. Isaac had been going to eat it. He looked at it, and filled the spoon, and put the handle in the old man's hand.

Rudd ate it slowly. He ate it the way he did everything since his eyes went, as if nothing else were happening anywhere. Then he wiped the spoon on his sleeve and gave it back.

That's good salmon, he said. *Thank you.* He stood with his face lifted, listening up the slope behind him. *Do you hear her?*

I hear it, said Isaac. *We're all going down. None of us is packing tomorrow. I told them at the tramway. I told the men there.* He nodded at the kettle, at the crowd. *They say Indians don't want to work on Sunday.*

They can't hear anything, said Rudd. *They've got Dawson in their ears.*

He found the rope again and went on down to Sheep Camp, and Isaac shouldered his empty pack frame and went after him.

III. Palm Sunday

Above Sheep Camp · April 3

THE FIRST SLIDE CAME DOWN ON THE TENTS AT THE SCALES AT two in the morning and buried twenty men, and they were all dug out alive. That frightened the ones who were left. Toward ten o'clock a second buried three people lower down, who were got out, and a third

KILLED THREE IN THEIR BLANKETS ON THE LONG HILL. THEN A whole crew of tramway men, coming down to camp, were caught in the ravine above the Stone House, and not one of them walked out.

A little before noon the people from the Scales started down together, some two hundred of them, in single file, holding to a rope, in snow so thick they could not see the man ahead. They were in the same ravine when the mountain let go. It made very little noise. It covered a third of them, some as deep as fifty feet.

Somebody fired a rifle, and somebody else, and within the hour there were fifteen hundred men up from Sheep Camp with shovels. They had been climbing over each other for eight months. Now they dug in lines, and passed the snow back hand to hand, and did not speak. They dug for four days. A few came out breathing. The rest were laid on sleds and brought down to a tent at Sheep Camp, sixty of them and more, nobody ever knew the right number, and a committee went through their pockets for names.

Mikkelsen's man at the Scales, a Swede named Lind, was under it. Mikkelsen dug for him with the others, and when Lind was found he went back down and moved three boilers up to the ravine, and for four days and nights he fed the diggers. He ladled it himself. Those were the last strokes that went into the black book. He thought, and he was ashamed of thinking it at such a time, that it was the best use the soup had ever been put to.

Isaac dug. So did his brothers and nine other men from the village, the ones who had said on Saturday that they were not going up.

Old Rudd could not dig. He sat on a sled at the mouth of the ravine with the widow's girl beside him. When the men down in the trench heard a voice under the snow and could not tell from where, they stopped and stood quiet and looked up at him, and he turned his covered face a little and pointed.

IV. The Yellow Rock

Sheep Camp · Easter Sunday, April 10

The girl was Nell Garrity. She was eleven. Her father had died at Sheep Camp of a fever in October, on his way to the Klondike. Her mother had turned his outfit into an eating tent with three plank tables, because the outfit was all they had and there was no money to go home on. Nell waited on the tables. She had carried beans and coffee to perhaps ten thousand men that winter. She was the one person at Sheep Camp, apart from Rudd, who was not going anywhere and did not want to. She had watched them all go by, and she had got so she could tell which ones would be back in a week selling their goods for the fare home. She did not think much of gold. She had seen what it looked like on people.

Above the last tents of the camp there was a boulder the size of a cabin, with yellow lichen all down its south face. It was the one dry place to sit in that canyon, and Rudd sat there in the mornings with his face to the sun he could not see, and Nell sat with him when her mother could spare her. She told him who was going by. He told her other things.

On Easter morning the snow had stopped at last. The dead were still in the long tent, waiting for the trail to be fit for the sleds, and the camp came up to the rock to hold some kind of service over them, since it was Easter and there were so many. They had sent to Dyea for a preacher. The preacher had not come. Six or seven hundred men stood about in the trampled snow with their hats in their hands, looking at each other.

Mikkelsen had come early. He had sat down on a bench close under the rock on the left side, and nobody thought that was anything but right.

Isaac had come up with his brothers and meant to stand at the back. Rudd heard his voice and called him. When Isaac came, the old man took hold of his sleeve and sat him down on the rock at Nell's right hand, and kept the sleeve.

Then the men who mattered began to arrive. First it was the citizens' committee, five of them, who had done the identifying. *Mr. Mikkelsen, would you mind?* He did not mind. He got up and took the second bench.

Then it was the lieutenant from the Fourteenth Infantry at Dyea, with a sergeant and a burial detail. After him came the superintendent of the tramway company, which had lost its whole crew, with his engineers, and the owners of the two hotels, and the doctor, and a man from the Dyea newspaper. Each time somebody touched Mikkelsen on the shoulder, very civilly, and each time he rose and moved back. He was a modest man. It did not seem to him a thing to make a difficulty about, on such a day.

The same men looked up at the rock, and at the packer sitting on it in his wool cap beside the child. More than one of them opened his mouth. Rudd had the sleeve. Nobody could find the way to begin, and Isaac stayed where he was.

Mikkelsen went back through the standing crowd, and then he was behind it. This is the part they tell at Sheep Camp, and he told it himself, in Tacoma, to the end of his life, and never changed it. He stepped back once more to make room for a man with a crutch, and when he looked around him he was not in the canyon. He was standing by a cold iron boiler under a canvas fly, on the shore of a frozen lake, with the boat-builders' tents of Bennett behind him. It was his own thirteenth kettle, at the far end of the whole row. There were thirty-three miles and a mountain between him and the yellow rock. He could see the rock. He could see the child on it as plainly as a figure on a clock across a room.

Somebody had asked Rudd to say the words, as the oldest man in the country.

I can't read them anymore, Rudd said. *She has it by heart. Stand up, Nell.*

She stood up on the rock in her mother's shawl. She had one piece by heart. She had learned it for the Sunday school at Sheep Camp, which was held Tuesdays in the dance hall. But she did not begin with it. She was looking over all their heads.

Mr. Mikkelsen! she said. It was her ordinary voice, the one she called orders in. They heard it at the Scales, and the kettle man at Dyea, on the tide flats, turned his head. *Mr. Mikkelsen, you fed everybody all winter. You had thirteen kettles. What are you doing clear back there?*

The crowd looked round, and could not see whom she was speaking to.

His answer came up the canyon small and clear. *I don't know, child. I have asked myself. I have given sixty-one thousand bowls of soup on this trail. That man beside you gave one spoonful of beans, I am told. And there he sits by you like the moon, and here am I, out among the little stars.* He was not complaining of it. He was a grocer, and he wanted to understand the account.

Nell turned. *Isaac. Why are you up here? Why didn't they move you?*

Isaac was a long time answering. He did not care to talk before so many of them. *I don't know about that,* he said. *If a man throws a sack of seed on the beach, the tide gets it. If he puts a little in good ground, he eats all winter.* He looked at the old man holding his sleeve. *I had a little. I put it in good ground. That's all.*

Then the child said the thing they remembered. She said it flatly, the way she would have told a man his eggs were coming.

You never looked who, Mr. Mikkelsen. You gave it to them going up. They weren't hungry for soup. They were hungry for the other thing, and they were so full of it there wasn't any room. It went straight through them. I saw them. They were mad at whoever was in front, and they didn't even know who you were, and all of them wanted and wanted. You can't put anything in a person like that. It's like planting in the fireweed. She put her hand on the red handkerchief beside her. *Mr. Rudd doesn't want anything. He isn't mad at anybody. He doesn't think he's anybody. So when you give him something it stays, and it's still there.*

And then she said her piece, with her hands behind her.

> *And some fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up, and choked it, and it yielded no fruit. And other fell on good ground, and did yield fruit that sprang up and increased; and brought forth, some thirty, and some sixty, and some an hundred.*
>
> *— Mark 4:7–8*

And then He tells what the thorns are, she said.

> *And these are they which are sown among thorns; such as hear the word, And the cares of this world, and the deceitfulness of riches, and the lusts of other things entering in, choke the word, and it becometh unfruitful.*
>
> *— Mark 4:18–19*

There was one more. It had been the Golden Text on a card, the Tuesday before the slide, and she had it still in her apron.

> *He that receiveth a prophet in the name of a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward; and he that receiveth a righteous man in the name of a righteous man shall receive a righteous man's reward. And whosoever shall give to drink unto one of these little ones a cup of cold water only in the name of a disciple, verily I say unto you, he shall in no wise lose his reward.*
>
> *— Matthew 10:41–42*

She sat down. That was the Easter service at Sheep Camp. Nobody added to it. The lieutenant's detail fired over the long tent, and the echo went up toward the summit and came back.

V. One Kettle

The Chilkoot Trail · April to June

Mikkelsen walked back. It took him three days, over the summit from the Bennett side, against the whole stream of them going the other way. He came past his own kettles one at a time, Lindeman, Deep Lake, Happy Camp, the Crater, and at each he stopped and looked at the men around it. He had never done that. He saw the eyes over the rims of the bowls, fixed on the trail. He saw that he could have fed them until the Judgment and they would not have known they had eaten.

He was not bitter. He told his wife afterward that it was like finding the error in a column that had refused to prove for eight months. The figure had been right. He had entered it on the wrong side of the book.

At Sheep Camp he went to the widow's tent and sat down across the plank from old Rudd, and asked if he might buy him his dinner, and Rudd said he might. They ate. Nell brought it. Mikkelsen watched how the old man took a thing that was given him. He took it whole. He did not look past it at anything else.

He struck twelve of the kettles before May. The thirteenth he kept, at Sheep Camp, and he stood at it himself. He did not ladle with his eyes down. He looked at each man who came. He turned nobody away. But he found that when he looked, there were some who could be given a thing, and some who had to be given it another day. He learned to tell the difference, slowly, as Nell had learned to tell who would be back in a week. He gave the sick a bed. He gave a boy from a hop farm his fare home, and the boy took it and wept and went, and that stayed where it was put. He stopped keeping the book.

Isaac packed until the tramways took the last of the trade. Then he went home to the inlet, and fished. Mikkelsen asked him once, before he left the country, to take something, anything, for the spoonful. Isaac laughed at him. *Then it's yours,* he said. *I'd sooner keep it mine.*

VI. Good Ground

Dyea · afterward

The railroad went over the other pass, from Skagway, and was through to Bennett in the summer of 1899. After that nobody had any reason to climb the Chilkoot. Dyea had been a town of several thousand, with a long wharf run out over the tide flats. In a few years it had hardly anyone in it, and the hotels were being pulled down for the lumber.

The dead of Palm Sunday who were not sent home were buried in a clearing in the spruce behind the town, in rows, and the soldiers of the Fourteenth helped make the ground ready. Every headboard there has the same date on it. Rudd is not among them. He died in his sleep at the widow Garrity's in the fall of 1898, the week the mail contract went to the railroad, and was buried in the little yard at Sheep Camp. Nell and her

mother went out on the last boat that year. She taught school in Ballard for thirty-eight years, and was known for being able to tell, in the first week, which of forty children could not be told anything yet, and for waiting.

Anker Mikkelsen went back to Tacoma and his scales. He sold groceries until 1911. He gave away a great deal after that winter, though less of it in money, and he was never again heard to say how much. When he died they found the black book in his desk with the total cast up on the last page. Under it, in another ink, in his bookkeeper's hand, he had written: *Cr., by one spoon beans, per Isaac. Balance carried.*

• • •

The Scales are nothing now. There is a flat of broken rock at the foot of the last climb, with a litter of rusted cable and boot soles and tin that the snow uncovers in July. The people who walk the trail in summer stop there to eat before they go up.

They say there is a place beside a certain boulder, on the downhill side, about where a man would have sat on his load. In the first week of August, most years, a bean vine comes up there through the stones. It has no business at that height. The frost is never a month off, and nothing else grows there but moss and a little heather. It climbs a hand's breadth and puts out two leaves and one white flower. Nobody has planted it. The rangers have stopped pulling it up.

Background

The verses

> *The fields are damaged by weeds, mankind is damaged by passion: therefore a gift bestowed on the passionless brings great reward.*
>
> Dhammapada 356, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The fields are damaged by weeds, mankind is damaged by hatred: therefore a gift bestowed on those who do not hate brings great reward.*
>
> Dhammapada 357, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The fields are damaged by weeds, mankind is damaged by vanity: therefore a gift bestowed on those who are free from vanity brings great reward.*
>
> Dhammapada 358, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *The fields are damaged by weeds, mankind is damaged by lust: therefore a gift bestowed on those who are free from lust brings great reward.*
>
> Dhammapada 359, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary the Buddha has gone up to the heaven of the Thirty-Three to teach, seated on the god Sakka's throne, the Yellowstone Rock. Two gods sit near him: Indaka at his right hand and Aṅkura at his left. As greater gods arrive, Aṅkura gives way to each until he is sitting twelve leagues off, while Indaka keeps his seat. In his human life Aṅkura had given alms for ten thousand years from a row of cooking-fires twelve leagues long; Indaka had once given a single spoonful of his own food to the elder Anuruddha. The Buddha asks Aṅkura why he sits so far away, and his voice is heard on earth. Aṅkura wonders that so small a gift outshines his "as the moon does the stars"; Indaka answers that he sowed a little seed in a good field. The Buddha tells Aṅkura that gifts should be given with discernment, and speaks the four verses. Read the full commentary story and the longer telling inside the story of the Twin Miracle, or about Anuruddha, the disciple whose bodily eyes failed and who was called foremost in the divine eye.

Sheep Camp, Chilkoot Trail, Alaska

The Chilkoot Trail, 1898

News of gold on the Klondike reached Seattle in July 1897, and within months tens of thousands of people were trying to reach the Yukon. Most landed at Skagway or at Dyea and crossed the Coast Mountains. The Chilkoot Trail, thirty-three miles from Dyea to Lake Bennett, was an old trade route owned and closely guarded by the Chilkoot Tlingit, many of whom now worked it as packers at rates that reached a dollar a pound. Canadian authorities required each person to bring a year's supply of food, so a stampeder had to relay close to a ton of goods over the pass, climbing it

dozens of times. Sheep Camp, the last stop below the summit, held several thousand people that winter. More on the Klondike Gold Rush.

After days of heavy snow and a warm south wind, a series of avalanches struck the trail above Sheep Camp on Palm Sunday, April 3, 1898. Native packers had refused to go above Sheep Camp that weekend. The slides came as the story gives them; the last, near noon, buried a column of people coming down from the Scales along a rope. Some fifteen hundred stampeders dug for four days. The dead are usually put at sixty to sixty-five. Many lie in the Slide Cemetery at Dyea, which soldiers of the Fourteenth Infantry helped prepare. The White Pass railroad from Skagway reached Lake Bennett in 1899, and Dyea emptied; its site and the trail are now part of Klondike Gold Rush National Historical Park. Mikkelsen and his kettles, Isaac, Rudd, the Garritys, the yellow rock and the Easter service are invented.

After the story of Aṅkura from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 356–359). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

Chapter 25

The Bhikshu

25.1

Singly None

Drops of water turn a mill,
Singly none, singly none.
— Constitution and Laws of the American Miners' Association (1864)

This is how I had it underground, at the Bluff shaft above La Salle.

I. Five Doors

La Salle County, Illinois · February 1865

The Bluff shaft went down better than three hundred feet to a vein of coal three and a half feet thick, and there were five doors in it.

A door in a coal pit keeps nobody out. It turns the air. A furnace burned day and night at the foot of the upcast and drew the foul air up that side of the shaft, and the good air fell down the other side to take its place. Left to itself the good air would have gone the forty yards across the pit bottom from the one to the other and never troubled the men at the coal half a mile in. So the short ways were shut with doors. The air came to a door, found it shut, and went the long way round, past every man lying on his side under the coal with his pick. It took his powder smoke with it, and the black damp that leaked out of the old workings, and carried them up and out. But the mules had to come through with the cars. So every door had a boy to pull it open for the trip and shut it after, and the company paid him fifty cents a day and called him a trapper.

Tommy Bate, whose father was a Staffordshire man, had the first door, forty yards in from the pit eye. Dai Rees had the second, far down the

main road, where nobody passed for an hour at a time. Jamie Laird had the door on the return, near the furnace and the mule stable. Con Doolan had the door by the turnout, where the men left their dinner tins on a ledge out of the wet. Sam Ogden had the last one, at the bottom of the dip, in water.

None of them was over twelve. They went down on the first cage and came up on the last, and in between they sat. A trapper's work is to sit on a plank in the dark with a cord in his hand and do nothing until he hears wheels, then do one thing, then sit again. Each boy had a tin lamp on his cap and blew it out between trips, because he bought his own oil.

On a Saturday in February the five of them were waiting for the cage at the end of the shift, in a row on a stack of props, and Tommy Bate said that his was the worst door in the pit.

There's that much to look at. The cage comes down, and I look. The stableman goes by with the grey mare, and I look. A driver has a new lamp. I'm not looking at anything, I'm only looking, and then the trip is on top of me and Shaughnessy is swearing and the door not open. You try sitting where you can see.

I'd give a week's pay to see anything, said Dai Rees. *There's nothing down my road but the dark, and you can't shut your ears the way you shut your eyes. The roof works. Water drips. Something walks that is too heavy for a rat. Wednesday I heard my mam call me to my tea, plain as that, and I was twenty yards up the road after her before I knew where I was. And the door standing, and a trip coming.*

You've only the one mam, Jamie Laird said. *Everything this pit has got comes by my door last. Powder reek. The mules. Forty men that have had onions. And Thursdays one of the furnacemen fries bacon on a shovel, and I tell you I would follow it to Peru.*

Peru was the next town down the river, a mile off, but he said it as if it were the other one.

Con Doolan said they could keep their bacon. He had his bread eaten by nine o'clock every morning of his life, and from nine until noon there were eleven dinner tins on the ledge an arm's length from where he sat, and he knew what was in every one. The drivers gave him a pull at their

cold tea going through, to be friendly, or a twist of tobacco. *And once there's a taste in your mouth there is nothing else in the pit. I've had a trip stand at my door and the mule looking at me.*

Sam Ogden waited until they were done. He was the smallest.

Mine's wet, he said. *I'm in it to the ankles. The door weighs more than I do and the wind comes under it fit to skin you. And twenty yards off there's a cut-through where the warm comes off the furnace drift, with dry slack on the floor.* He looked at his boots. *I've a bit of sacking there. I'm not saying I lie on it.*

Each of them held that the other four had no notion. They were still at it when the cage came. Then Tommy Bate said there was one man who had walked through all five doors every morning for nine years and would know, and they would ask Evan Lamp.

II. Evan Lamp

The pit eye · Monday, before the shift

Evan Pugh was the fireman. They called him Evan Lamp because there were three Evans at the Bluff and he was the one who carried the Davy. He came from Monmouthshire. He was near sixty, which is old for underground, and he had a blue line across the bridge of his nose where a cut had healed with the coal still in it.

He went down alone at four every morning, two hours before the men. He carried the safety lamp with the wick pricked low, and he walked every road in the pit and went into every place where a man would work that day. He watched the flame. He laid his left hand flat to the roof and rapped beside it with a stick and listened. He smelled the air at the mouths of the old workings, and drew it in over his tongue, as the old firemen at home did, who said a man could taste black damp, sour, before it dimmed his light. He wet his cheek and turned it to feel which way the air was going. Where a place was fit he chalked the day of the month on the coal and E.P. under it, and no man at the Bluff put a pick to a face that did not show that morning's chalk. Illinois had no law yet for the safety of coal pits. It was the custom, brought over with the men, and the lodge held to it.

The five were standing at the pit eye when he came out of the main road with the lamp. They had begged down on the first cage on purpose. Tommy Bate put the question, and each of the others put in what Tommy left out.

Evan Lamp heard them through. He looked along the row, and he did not look at any one of them longer than at the next.

They are all hard doors, he said. *I never found the easy one.*

Then he said, *I know you five. I have known you a long while.*

Since the summer, said Sam Ogden, who had come in July.

Since the Gelli pit. Forty-three years. There are always five, and it is always you. He hung the lamp on a nail in a prop, out of the draught. *You have a quarter of an hour before the first trip. Sit down.*

III. The Gelli

Monmouthshire · 1822

He had been fourteen, he said, and carried the fireman's tools. The fireman was Lewis Probert, who had the first Davy lamp in that valley. The Gelli was a fiery pit and made gas at every fall. There were five doors between the Deep and the pit eye, and five boys on them, and every one of those boys Lewis Probert had told the same thing in the same three words. *Keep your door.*

One morning Probert took him into the Deep and held up the lamp, and the flame put on a cap. It was a blue cap as long as a thumb, sitting on the yellow. *She is in,* Probert said. He stayed behind to hang sheets across the road and turn what air there was, and he gave the boy the lamp to carry out to the overman, so that the overman should see the cap with his own eyes and keep the men on top. He told him three things. Hold it level. Walk, because a Davy will pass its flame through the gauze if you run with it. And do not stop to look at her. *She is very pretty,* he said, *and that is all she is.*

So the boy walked. The cap should have shrunk as he came out toward good air. It grew.

He came to the fifth door and it was standing open with a sprag under it. The trapper had found a warm place off the road and was asleep in it; his feet stuck out. *That was you, Sam.* The fourth door was open, and the boy who kept it was down the turnout with his arm in another man's dinner. The third had gone toward the stable after a smell of something. The second had heard singing in the old workings and gone to find it, and Evan Lamp said that in forty-three years he had never learned who was singing. The first was at the pit eye with his back to his door, watching them lower a white pony down the shaft in a sling.

Five doors open. The air had no call to go round by the Deep. It went straight across from shaft to shaft, and the gas had the roads to herself. She came along behind him the whole way, door after door, as near as his heels, and he could see her in the lamp. By the second door the gauze was full of blue to the top. He said it was the prettiest color he had seen above ground or below it, like the inside of a mussel shell, and it was warm on his hand. He did not run and he did not stop. He looked at the road.

The overman had a cabin at the pit eye. The boy held the lamp up to him and said what Lewis Probert had said. The overman had been thirty years in that pit. He said there had never been gas in the main road and the lamp was foul, and anything found in his pit was his to judge. He took it into the cabin to have a proper look at her. He sent the boy up in the cage with a word for the agent.

I had one foot on the bank, Evan Lamp said, *when she fired.*

He took the lamp down off the nail.

Fifty-two men and boys. The five trappers were not found, to speak of. Lewis Probert they found behind his sheets with no mark on him, where the afterdamp had come to him. When the pit was opened again and the boy had his growth, they gave him Probert's place, because he was the one who had seen her and kept walking. He had had a lamp in his hand ever since.

IV. Chalk

The Bluff shaft

Nobody said anything. The cage was coming down again. They could hear the rope.

I do not ask which of you has the worst door, Evan Lamp said. *The air does not ask. It tries all five and goes by whichever one is open, and then it is no matter how well the other four were kept. A door is no use by itself. And every one of you has all five to mind, at whatever door you're sat. Your eyes, your ears, your nose, your mouth, and the whole skin of you. When you have minded those, there is your tongue to keep still, and your wits to keep by you, and that last is the hardest, and it keeps the rest.*

He asked Tommy Bate whether his father had the Association's book of laws in the house. Tommy said he had. It was on the shelf with the clock.

Then you have seen what is printed on the front of it. Say it.

Tommy knew it. He said it standing up, the way he had heard the men say it, and by the fifth line the other four were saying it with him.

> *Step by step, the longest march*
> *Can be won, can be won;*
> *Single stones will form an arch,*
> *One by one, one by one.*
> *And, by union, what we will*
> *Can be all accomplished still.*
> *Drops of water turn a mill,*
> *Singly none, singly none.*
>
> *— Constitution and Laws of the American Miners' Association (1864), title page*

Your fathers mean wages by that, Evan Lamp said. *It is true of wages. It is true of doors.*

Then the first trip was calling from the turnout, and they went to their planks.

• • •

He never told it again that anybody heard. That spring the men at the far end of the Deep, who had worked all winter with their lamps burning straight up and a pain behind the eyes by noon, noticed that the flames on their caps leaned toward the return and stayed leaning, shift after shift, and that the smoke of a shot was gone before they had walked back to look at the coal. Sam Ogden's sacking lay in the cut-through until the rats had it. Con Doolan sat with his back to the ledge. Dai Rees took to counting his own breaths in the quiet, out loud, up to a hundred and over again, and anything that called him had to call over the top of that.

And in the mornings, when the five came to their doors, the day of the month was there in chalk on each one, at the height of a boy's eyes, with E.P. under it, the same as on the coal.

Background

The verses

> *Restraint in the eye is good, good is restraint in the ear, in the nose restraint is good, good is restraint in the tongue.*
>
> Dhammapada 360, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *In the body restraint is good, good is restraint in speech, in thought restraint is good, good is restraint in all things. A Bhikshu, restrained in all things, is freed from all pain.*
>
> Dhammapada 361, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five monks have each taken one of the five sense doors to guard, and they fall to arguing over whose door is the hardest. They ask the Buddha. He will not set one above another: all the doors are hard, he says, and this is not the first time the five of them have failed at it. He then tells the birth story of the road to Takkasilā, in which five guards walking with a prince through a haunted forest are drawn off one at a time by a sight, a sound, a scent, a taste and a soft couch, and are eaten by the ogresses who laid them out; the prince walks on with an ogress at his heels, does not look at her, and is made king after the king who took her in is devoured with his household. Read the full commentary story, the birth story of the bowl of oil it summarizes, or about the sense bases.

La Salle, Illinois

La Salle, Illinois, 1865

The American Miners' Association, the first national miners' union in the United States, was founded in January 1861 at West Belleville, Illinois, by British-born miners, some of them old Chartists. By 1863 it had lodges in the deep shafts around La Salle, opened in 1856 where the Illinois and Michigan Canal met the river, and it held its convention there that March, a month after the legislature passed the anti-strike statute the miners called the La Salle Black Laws. The union was gone by 1869. The verse stands on the title page of its 1864 constitution, reproduced in Edward Wieck's *The American Miners' Association* (1940); in the twentieth century it was set to music as "Step by Step." Illinois passed no mine-safety law until the 1870s, and what protection the men had was the custom they carried from British pits.

Mines of the period were ventilated by a furnace that drew air through the workings, and the current was steered by wooden doors kept by boys called trappers, a job described in the article on child labor in British pits. The Davy lamp of 1815 enclosed its flame in wire gauze; in firedamp the flame lengthened and took a blue cap, and in black damp it sank and went out. The man who carried one through the pit before each shift was the fireman, later the fire boss. The Bluff shaft, the Gelli pit and everyone in them are invented.

After the story of the five bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 360–361). The original. Verse from the title page of the Constitution and Laws of the American Miners' Association (1864). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.2

Skill and Sport

And do not seek to take the life
Which you can never give.
— "Don't Kill the Birds," McGuffey's Third Eclectic Reader

The way I heard it told, on the north side of the Minidoka project.

I. The Bar

Norland, Minidoka County, Idaho · Saturday, September 12, 1914

Orrin Sayles and Walt Brandt had stood up together in May in the basement of the Methodist church, each with his right hand raised and three fingers straight, and said the Oath and the twelve points of the Law in front of Mr. Harbison and eleven other boys. They were thirteen. After that night you did not see the one without the other.

On the second Saturday in September they walked the three miles down to the river to swim. A Scout had to swim fifty yards to make First Class, and below the old ferry the Snake had a slack place behind a gravel bar where a boy could pace it off. They swam it four times apiece. Then they lay on the bar to dry, with the stones warm under them, and talked about nothing, the way you can with one person.

The desert came down to the water on both banks. Seven years before there had been nothing on the north side but sage and jackrabbits and wind. Then the government dam went in above, and the canal, and people came from Iowa and Nebraska and Utah and took eighty acres apiece, and now when you stood on the bluff you could see the exact line where the laterals stopped, green on this side of it and gray on that. Above the dam the lake was a bird reservation by order of the President,

and nobody could fire a gun there. The geese knew it. They traded up and down the river all that month.

Two of them came up the channel now, low, one a little behind the other.

Orrin sat up. He had the best arm on the project. He pitched for the Norland nine against grown men from the south side, and at the rabbit drives he never carried a club. He picked a pebble off the bar.

I'm going to hit that near one in the eye.

You can't, Walt said.

I'll put it in the eye on this side and out the eye on the other.

You can't do that either.

Watch.

The first stone went behind the near goose. It heard the stone go by and turned its head to look back. Orrin had the second one in his hand already, a round one the size of a walnut, and that was the one. It went in at the far eye and came out at the near. The goose cried once and fell, turning over, and struck the gravel a yard from their feet. The other went on up the river, and they could hear it a long time.

Told you, Orrin said.

Walt did not say anything.

Three older boys of the troop were on the bank above with a pair of signal flags. Emmett Lund, who was fifteen and had the Beaver Patrol, came down onto the bar. He looked at the goose and then at Orrin.

Number six, he said. *Say it.*

A Scout is kind.

All of it.

Orrin said all of it. *He is a friend to animals. He will not kill nor hurt any living creature needlessly, but will strive to save and protect all harmless life.*

Pick it up, Emmett said. *We're going to Mr. Harbison. You too, Walt. You told him he couldn't.*

II. The Prescription Case

Harbison's Drug, on the square

Lyle Harbison had come to the project in 1908 from a ditch farm in Colorado by way of a pharmacy course in Denver, and he kept the only drugstore in Norland. He was forty-four and unmarried. He had started the troop two years back because he was asked, and because nobody else would, and the Methodists lent the basement.

On Saturdays the farm families were in town and the fountain was three deep. The five boys came in the alley door. Orrin had the goose rolled in his shirt.

Mr. Harbison was behind the prescription case counting tablets onto a tile with a spatula, by fives. He looked up and saw who it was and what the shirt had in it. He looked down again and finished the count, funneled the tablets into a bottle, wrote the label, and pasted it on square. Then he wiped his hands and came around.

He unrolled the shirt on the back counter. He turned the head with one finger, this way and that way.

Orrin. Is this yours?

Yes, sir.

With a stone.

Two. The first one was to make him turn his head.

Mr. Harbison stood a while. Out front the fountain hissed and a child was asking for strawberry.

"And do not seek to take the life which you can never give," he said. *I had that out of the Third Reader when I was nine years old. I thought it was about sparrows.*

He folded the shirt back over the bird.

You took an oath in May. Nobody made you. You walked three miles in the dark to take it. And I have known people who never took one, who never heard of a Scout in their lives, plain farmers with a family to feed, who were more careful than that over a good deal less. You weren't careful over this at all.

It was Walt who asked. *What people?*

III. The Upper Ditch

Colorado · about 1880, as he told it

When he was a boy, Mr. Harbison said, there were two ditches out of the same river. His father farmed under the Upper. The one below was called the Fairview. They had the same river and near enough the same decree, and on the Upper the water got to the last man on the last lateral every August, dry years too, and on the Fairview it quit halfway down and the bottom forty farms burned up.

The Fairview people studied on it and decided it was the horse. The Upper had a ditch rider named Dunham who rode a gelding black as stove polish, and it was said along the river that water followed that horse. So one July the Fairview board drove up and hired him off the Upper for the season. They paid forty dollars, in gold. Their own rider rode the black horse up and down the Fairview until September, and the bottom forty burned up the same as before.

The next spring they came back with a tablet and a pencil. They said, *Write down for us how you people run your ditch. Whatever the rule is, we will have it lettered on a board in gilt and hang it in our headgate house.*

The Upper people did not know they had a rule. So the Fairview men went around and asked them one at a time.

The president of the ditch said he was not the man to ask. On the Fourth of July he had fired his rifle into the air, once for each quarter of the Union, and he had never found where the fourth ball came down. For all he knew it came down on something living in the reservoir. He could not say he had kept any rule.

His mother said she had given her good shawl to one daughter-in-law and a sack of dried apples to the other, and had felt mean about it ever since. Dunham the ditch rider said that he had once driven a stake for a measuring box into a crawdad hole and never knew whether the crawdad was at home. The man who hauled for the company said he had touched up his team with the whip to beat a storm in, and they were willing horses and had not needed it. The storekeeper, who was treasurer, had pulled a head of wheat in a field worked on shares, to see was it ripe, be-

fore the landlord's third was measured out, and that head was a third the landlord's. The man who kept time on the water turns said it had come on to rain once while he was counting out a turn, and he ran for the shed and lost his count, and it might be he gave one neighbor a minute of another neighbor's water. The tender at the headgate had cursed a man who came for the key after dark with a woman on the wagon seat, and she turned out to be the man's sister.

There was a widow at the end of the last lateral who took in sewing. A stranger had paid her five dollars ahead on a suit of clothes and never come back to be measured. She had turned away other work for three years on account of that five dollars, and gone short, and she was not sure but that somewhere in the third year she had begun to wish him ill.

Every one of them said the same thing, Mr. Harbison said. *Don't put my name to it. I can't say I've kept it.*

The Fairview men said there was nothing in any of that. A crawdad. A minute of water. The Upper people said maybe not. The Fairview men wrote it all down regardless, and what it came to, when they boiled it, was five lines. Don't kill what you have no need to. Don't take what isn't yours. Leave another man's household be. Say what is so. Come to the headgate sober. They had it lettered on a board in gilt and hung it up, and what is more they kept it, and the next August there was water at the bottom of the Fairview.

It never was the horse, he said. *A ditch is nine miles of people. The water gets to the end if nobody along the way takes a little that isn't his. And people who will lie awake over a crawdad don't reach down at night and lift a headgate.*

IV. Two. One.

The back counter

Those were farmers, Mr. Harbison said. *Nobody had sworn them to anything. And you stood up with your hand in the air.*

He looked at Orrin's hands, which were hanging at his sides.

I have watched you pitch. Those hands will do whatever you tell them, and that is not common. It is a thing to be careful with, the way I am careful with what is in the blue bottles. Your hands. Where your feet take you. And your mouth, Orrin. This didn't start with a stone. It started with "Watch."

He went to the shelf over the desk where he kept the Pharmacopoeia and the Dispensatory, and brought down a thick book in a brown binding, the first of two.

This man could throw. I know what is said about him on Sundays, and this is not that part. This is his son writing.

> *He once killed a hare sitting in the flower-garden at Shrewsbury by throwing a marble at it, and, as a man, he once killed a cross-beak with a stone. He was so unhappy at having uselessly killed the cross-beak that he did not mention it for years, and then explained that he should never have thrown at it if he had not felt sure that his old skill had gone from him.*
>
> *— Francis Darwin, The Life and Letters of Charles Darwin (1887), vol. I, ch. III*

He was a good shot besides. He went around the world on a ship, shooting birds for his collection wherever it put in, and somewhere on the way he handed the gun to his servant and did not ask for it back. He says why himself.

> *I discovered, though unconsciously and insensibly, that the pleasure of observing and reasoning was a much higher one than that of skill and sport.*
>
> *— Charles Darwin, Autobiography, in Life and Letters, vol. I, ch. II*

He could sit by a pond any number of hours watching a float, by himself, and want nothing. I don't expect you to believe on a Saturday afternoon that looking is better than hitting. You could find out.

He shut the book.

Now. It is killed, and it is September, and Mrs. Aiken on the A-2 lateral has five at the table and no man. The two of you will pluck it and draw it and carry it out to her. When she asks where you came by a goose, tell her.

She asked. They told her.

• • •

Orrin Sayles pitched for Norland until the war and for a sugar-factory team after it, and nobody ever again saw him throw at a living thing. Some days he would pick a stone up off the road and carry it a while, and you would see him set it down. He did not speak of the goose. Walt Brandt, who knew, did not speak of it either.

But Orrin went down to the bar by himself most evenings that fall and sat until dark, and in the back of his Handbook, on the blank leaves they give you for notes, there is a list in pencil.

Sept. 12. Canada geese going up the river. 2. 1.

Sept. 13. 1, same place. Calling.

Sept. 14. 1.

It goes on that way down the page, a date and a number, with the ones giving out toward the end of the month and the numbers getting larger. The last line of that year says, *Oct. 9. Counted to 300 and quit. They were still coming.*

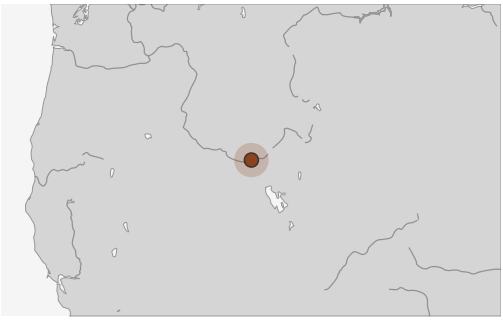
Background

The verse

> *He who controls his hand, he who controls his feet, he who controls his speech, he who is well controlled, he who delights inwardly, who is collected, who is solitary and content, him they call Bhikshu.*
>
> Dhammapada 362, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, two young monks who were ordained together and go everywhere together bathe in the river Aciravatī and stand drying in the sun. Two geese fly over. One monk says he can put a stone through a goose's eye, the near one and then the far; his friend says he cannot; the first pebble makes the bird turn its head and the second goes in at one eye and out at the other. Other monks bring the pair to the Buddha, who asks if it is true, and then tells them that householders long ago had scruples over far smaller things. His story is the birth story of the Kuru rule: a kingdom without rain borrows a neighbor king's lucky black elephant, gets no rain,

and sends to have the neighbor's five precepts written on a gold plate; the king, his mother, his surveyor, his charioteer, his treasurer, his grain-measurer, his gatekeeper, a courtesan and others each protest that they cannot be sure they have kept them, on account of some trifle; the precepts are copied and kept, and the rain comes. Read the full commentary story and the birth story of the Kurus.



Minidoka County, Idaho

The Minidoka project, 1914

The Minidoka Project was one of the first works of the federal Reclamation Service. It was approved in 1904; Minidoka Dam on the Snake River was finished in 1906 and the north-side canal in 1907, and settlers took up farm units of eighty acres in what had been sagebrush. The lake behind the dam was set aside in 1909 as a bird reservation, now the Minidoka National Wildlife Refuge. Norland, its drugstore and its people are invented; Rupert, the project town nearby, is real.

The Boy Scouts of America was four years old in 1914. The sixth point of its Scout Law is quoted here as printed in the first Handbook (1911), which also required a First Class Scout to swim fifty yards. The year before, the Weeks–McLean Act had put migratory birds under federal protection for the first time, and on September 1, 1914, eleven days before this story, Martha, the last passenger pigeon, died in the Cincinnati Zoo. "Don't Kill the Birds" is Lesson LV of the 1879 McGuffey's Third Eclectic Reader. Darwin's recollections, and his son's account of the cross-beak, are in the first volume of the *Life and Letters* (1887).

After the story of the goose-killing bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 362). The original. Texts from *The Life and Letters of Charles Darwin* (1887), McGuffey's Third Eclectic Reader (1879) and the Boy Scouts Handbook (1911). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.3

Two Walls

> *The third tongue (i.e., slander) hurts three parties: the slanderer himself, the receiver of slander, and the person slandered.*
> *— Talmud, Erchin 15b*

Azoy hot men mir ibergegebn, on the porches of Sharon Springs.

I. The Back Room

Sharon Springs, Schoharie County, New York · June 1954

The whole village smelled of the water. It came out of the hill as white as skim milk and stinking of eggs, and people had been riding up from the city to sit in it for a hundred years: first the Vanderbilts, then the German Jews whom Saratoga would not have, then the Jews from Galicia and Hungary, and now, since the war, the ones who had come through the other thing with their joints and their skin and their nerves in such a state that a doctor on the Grand Concourse could only tell them to go and take the baths. They drank the water out of paper cups at the temple with the white columns. They lay in it in the tubs at the Imperial for twenty minutes by the attendant's clock, and were wrapped in sheets and left to sweat. In the afternoons they sat in rocking chairs on the porches, porch below porch down the one steep street, and talked.

Koppel Weingast had the porch halfway down. He had come from Galicia in 1922, a yeshiva boy with a good head and a quicker mouth, and had gone into boarders. Weingast's was not the Adler, which had a hundred and fifty rooms. It was eleven rooms and two kitchens, one for meat and one for dairy, where the women cooked for their own, and a front parlor where he kept a minyan going from Shavuos to the High Holidays.

He read the Torah for them and blew the shofar in Elul. He also knew who on the street was taking the waters for what, and on whose money, and whose daughter was not married and why, and he told it, rocking, to whoever had the next chair. Nobody called him a bad man. They called him Koppel the Radio.

The week after Shavuos two men got down from the Albany bus with one cardboard valise between them. They wore cloth caps and short jackets, like any two greeners from a shop on Broome Street. The taller one had a number on his forearm and carried his right shoulder high. The other was small and round and walked as if the sidewalk interested him. They asked on the street for Weingast.

Koppel knew them before they were up the steps. He had gone to the Rebbe in Williamsburg for one Shabbos every winter since 1947, and nobody who had sat at that table needed telling who stood at the Rebbe's right hand and who at his left. The small one was Reb Shaya, who could take a page of Gemara that had beaten a roomful of scholars and say it over so that a wagon driver followed it. The tall one was Reb Mottel, about whom people told things with their voices down: that he had been seen in two places on one afternoon; that he had said to a woman in the Rebbe's kitchen, *Your brother is alive, he is in Montevideo,* and the letter came inside the month. On Hewes Street the two of them could not get from the door to the corner without ten hands on their sleeves.

Koppel's mouth was already open. Reb Shaya put up one finger.

Reb Koppel. It would be pleasant for us to stay by you, and for you to have us. We would stay the summer.

How would it be pleasant for you, by me?

If you tell no living person who we are. Two boarders. Shaya and Mottel from the city, for the rheumatism.

And for me, how pleasant?

Every night when your house is asleep, we will learn with you. The three months.

Koppel Weingast had not had anyone to learn with since 1922.

Stay as long as you want, he said, and he gave them the back room over the dairy kitchen, which was the quiet one and got the morning sun.

They stayed until the end of Av. They went down to the Imperial at seven like everybody else, with towels. They ate what they cooked themselves, and it was little. The rest of the day the door of the back room was shut, and if a boarder asked, Koppel said they were two quiet men who were not well. At eleven at night he came down to the dairy kitchen and they were at the table with the book open. Reb Shaya explained. It was all he did, and he did it the way another man pours water, and Koppel, who had believed for thirty years that he remembered how to learn, found out that he had never yet been taught. Reb Mottel mostly listened. Once, without turning his head, he said, *Koppel, the milk,* and Koppel got to the stove just as it rose.

Nobody on the street knew. It was the best summer of Koppel's life, and it was like carrying a hot potato in his mouth from Shavuos to the end of Av.

II. Beheimes

Main Street · the last week of Av

They were going back to the Rebbe for Elul, as a hasid does. Koppel carried the valise up the hill himself. The three of them stopped at Mrs. Sobel's for a glass of tea and a roll, and then the two went on to the corner of Route 20 to wait for the bus, and Koppel started home.

It was three in the afternoon. The porches were full. He got as far as the middle of the street, where both sides could hear him.

Beheimes! he said. Cattle. *Cows in a field! Three months Reb Shaya and Reb Mottel of Hlinitz sat among you. The Rebbe's right hand and the Rebbe's left. In my back room, over my dairy kitchen. Pincus, one of them lay in the next tub to you at the Imperial, and you told him he was using too many towels. And you knew nothing. Nothing! And now they are standing at the corner for the Albany bus.*

The rocking stopped all the way down the hill.

Why didn't you tell us? said Mrs. Sobel from her doorway.

Then everybody was moving. A honey cake came out of a kitchen still in its pan. Somebody had a bottle of slivovitz put by for a son's engage-

ment. A furrier from the Bronx, who was taking the cure for his hands, went up the stairs two at a time for a wool blanket still in its paper. The doctor's widow brought liniment and a tin of salve. Envelopes were found, and bills put into them. They went up Main Street in a body, thirty people, some of them in slippers, and Koppel went with them, at the back. He was thinking that those two ate like birds and owned one valise between them. They would never take such things. And when they did not take them, the things would have to be left with somebody.

The bus was late. The two men were standing by the post with the valise between their feet.

Forgive us, Mrs. Sobel said. *We didn't know who you were. We heard it this minute, from Reb Koppel. Have pity on us and take.*

Reb Shaya looked at the cake and the bottle and the blanket and the envelopes. He looked for a moment at Koppel.

A present that a man gives because another man's tongue went and fetched it out of him, we don't take, he said. *Carry it home. You should all be well.*

He did not say, give it to Koppel. Reb Mottel did not say it either. Thirty people stood holding what they had brought.

Then come again, said Pincus, *and give us a blessing.*

We'll come.

The bus came. Koppel carried nothing home, and it was a week before anyone on the street saw him rock.

III. Two Buses

Sharon Springs · after Tisha b'Av, 1955

They kept their word the next summer, and they did not come alone. Two chartered buses stopped at the corner of Route 20, and sixty of the Rebbe's hasidim got down from them in their long coats, gray men and boys, behind Reb Shaya and Reb Mottel. The street had been waiting since Shavuos. The hotel keepers had drawn lots for who would house whom, and none of them would take a dollar. The two asked for the back room at Weingast's, and had it.

Every day there was honor, and every day something came up the hill. A manufacturer in Gloversville sent five dozen pairs of lined gloves against the winter. The furrier sent to the city for knitted vests. The bath people sent books of tickets. There was medicine, and a case of wine. The hasidim who had come on the buses shared it all out among the sixty, a pair to each and a vest to each, down to the boys. To Koppel, who lived there, who was standing in his own parlor while they did it, nobody thought to hand anything. Reb Shaya and Reb Mottel did not hand him anything either.

That night he was in his chair on the porch, and the next chair was not empty.

Last year a honey cake was beneath them. This year they take with both hands. Gloves they take. Wine they take. Holy men! There is no bottom to those two. They want and they want, and whoever else is standing there can go whistle.

He said it on Monday on the porch. He said it Tuesday at the temple with a paper cup in his hand, and Wednesday at the Imperial to Earl, the Gentile who ran the tubs, who had no idea what he was talking about. By Thursday it had gone down one side of Main Street and come back up the other, as things did there, and it reached the back room over the dairy kitchen.

Friday before light the two buses were at the corner with their motors running.

The street came out in its bathrobes. *Stay for Shabbos. Stay till Sunday. What did we do?* Reb Shaya said they had done nothing, they should be well, and got on. It was one of the young ones, a boy of eighteen with his foot on the step, who turned around and said it.

Where should they stay? Your own Reb Koppel doesn't want them here.

They were on Koppel's porch before the buses were over the hill.

Go after them, Pincus said. *Ask their pardon and bring them back. Or else pack, and keep boarders somewhere else.*

Koppel was frightened. He paid the hack to go after them, and caught the buses at a diner near Duanesburg where the drivers had stopped for

coffee. He stood at the door of the first bus with his hat in his hand, and asked.

Go home, Reb Koppel, Reb Shaya said. He did not say it hard. *We are not coming back.*

On the street they were waiting for him.

So?

I couldn't persuade them.

Why not?

He had no answer that could be said out loud.

They talked it over on the porches that Shabbos, without him. A house where a man like that had the reading and the keys, they said, no decent Jew would set foot in again. On Sunday morning his boarders paid up, all eleven rooms, and moved down the hill to Mrs. Feder's, and the minyan moved with them. Pincus came for the key to the ark. He had known Koppel thirty years.

Koppel, he said, *don't sit here any more. We have nothing for you here.*

IV. Three Times

Hewes Street, Williamsburg · Elul

He shut the house and took the bus to the city and went to the Rebbe.

The Rebbe of Hlinitz had come out of the war with one lung and no one of his own, and he held his table on the parlor floor of a brownstone with the wall knocked through. He was not a man who spoke. People said that since 1945 he had used perhaps a hundred words a week, and most of those on children. The gabbai let Koppel in after the evening prayer.

Koppel did not wait to be asked.

Rebbe. Shaya and Mottel are takers. They are in the hands of their appetites, the both of them.

Don't say that, Koppel, the Rebbe said. *Have trust in Shaya and Mottel. They are good.*

The Rebbe believes in them. I am the one who saw. With my eyes. A year they wouldn't touch, and then with both hands.

Don't say that, Koppel. Have trust in Shaya and Mottel. They are good.

They have things hidden inside them. They are not what the Rebbe thinks. They are bad men.

Don't say that, Koppel, the Rebbe said the third time, and the rest of it after, in the same voice, like a man holding a door for somebody who will not come through it.

Koppel got up from the chair. A hasid leaves the Rebbe walking backward, with his face to him. Koppel turned around and walked out.

On the stairs his neck itched. Under the lamp in the vestibule he looked at the backs of his hands, and they were covered with small hard grains under the skin, the size of mustard seed. They were on his wrists, and when he pulled his collar open, on his chest. By the time he had the street door open they were the size of chickpeas. On the stoop they were like crab apples, and hot, and then they began to break. He got as far as the iron gate. The men coming in for the late study found him lying against it, groaning, with his shirt stuck to him, and his mouth, they said afterward, still going.

Before the ambulance came from Greenpoint the word was at the corner. Before midnight it was in every shtiebel from the bridge to Flushing Avenue: Koppel Weingast spoke against Reb Shaya and Reb Mottel, to the Rebbe's face, three times. They say it went farther than Williamsburg. They say it was heard that night in places where the news of this world does not as a rule arrive.

V. Reb Tuvia

Greenpoint Hospital · the second night

KOPPEL HAD HAD A TEACHER ONCE, IN HLINITZ. REB TUVIA the dayan had taken him into his own house, an orphan of seven with a mouth on him, and taught him for nothing until he was seventeen. Reb Tuvia died in his bed in 1931, a very old man, and the whole town said the same thing at the grave: there went one who had finished, one of those who are not sent back.

On the second night in the ward Koppel opened his eyes, and Reb Tuvia was standing at the foot of the bed. The man in the next bed, a Pole with his leg in traction, swore for the rest of his life that the old Jew stood a hand's breadth above the linoleum.

Koppel. It is a cruel thing you did. Make your peace with those two.

Who are you?

Tuvia. Your teacher.

You? Koppel got up on one elbow. Nothing about him worked any more except the one thing. *You were supposed to be finished. All Hlinitz said it. A soul that doesn't have to come back. So what are you doing back? A fine tzaddik! You know what you'll be? A ghost on a garbage dump, that's what you'll be.*

Reb Tuvia looked at him the way he had looked at him across the Gemara when he was seven.

Let it be for you, Koppel, he said, *according to your own mouth.*

Then there was only the foot of the bed.

Koppel Weingast died before morning. They buried him the same day in the Hlinitzer society's ground in Queens, and Reb Shaya and Reb Mottel were two of the men who carried him.

A week later one of the hasidim, who could not leave a thing alone, asked the Rebbe at the door where Koppel was now. The Rebbe was quiet so long that the man began to back away. Then he said what stands in the old books.

> *The soul of a slanderer is transmigrated into a silent stone.*
>
> *— Emek ha-Melekh, in Hebraic Literature (1901)*

VI. The Third Meal

Hewes Street · Shabbos Shuva

On the Sabbath of Return, at the third meal, the light goes and nobody may kindle a lamp, and the hasidim sit on at the long table in the dark with a piece of challah and a piece of herring and sing

without words. Between one tune and the next the talk that week was Koppel.

His mouth buried him.

Thirty years a decent Jew, and one summer.

If he had only swallowed it.

The Rebbe heard them. *It was not the first time,* he said, and because he so seldom said anything, sixty men stopped chewing. *That soul fell by its mouth once before.*

There was a tortoise, he said, in a pond in the mountains. Two wild geese came down on that pond and stayed a season, and the three of them became friends. When the cold was coming the geese said, *We winter in a cave of gold on a mountain far from here. It is a good place. Come with us.*

How does a tortoise come?

We will carry you. If you can keep your mouth shut.

I can keep it shut.

So they found a stick, and the tortoise bit down on the middle of it, and the geese took the two ends in their beaks and went up.

They flew over a village. The boys in the road looked up. *Look! Two geese carrying a turtle on a stick!*

And the tortoise thought, *You little nothings, if my friends are carrying me, what is it to you?* And he opened his mouth to tell them.

He came down in the courtyard of the lord of that country, the Rebbe said, on the paving, and broke in two.

Nobody at the table sang.

He had hold of the stick, the Rebbe said. *He was already in the air.*

Then he said the Gemara in Erchin, in the holy tongue, the few words of it. And Reb Shaya, at his right hand, said it over after him in plain Yiddish for the boys at the bottom of the table, slowly, and it was a hard saying, and from him it was sweet to hear.

> *The Holy One—blessed be He!—said to the tongue, "All the members of the body are erect, thou only art recumbent; all other members are without, thou art within, and not only so, for I have surrounded thee with two walls, one of bone and the other of flesh. What shall be given to thee, or what shall be added unto thee, O thou false tongue?"*
>
> *— Talmud, Erchin 15b, in Hebraic Literature (1901)*

In the dark somebody began the tune again, and the rest came in.

• • •

Weingast's stood shut the next summer, and the summer after that it was sold. The two came back to Sharon Springs every year for the rheumatism, with one valise, and stayed where there was a room, and the street let them alone.

Below the Imperial a wall of laid stone holds the bank of Brimstone Creek, and every stone in it is crusted white from the water. On their first morning each summer, coming up from the baths with their towels, the two would stop there, and Reb Mottel would put his palm flat on one of the stones, a little above the waterline, for about as long as it takes to say a short prayer. It was always the same stone. Nobody asked him. If you went down afterward and laid your own hand on it, it was warm, but in July every stone in that wall is warm.

Background

The verse

> *The Bhikshu who controls his mouth, who speaks wisely and calmly, who teaches the meaning and the law, his word is sweet.*
>
> Dhammapada 363, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the two chief disciples, Sāriputta and Moggallāna, want a season away from the crowd and spend the three months of the rains with the monk Kokālika on one condition: that he tell nobody who they are. In return they teach him. As they leave he cannot hold it any longer and tells the village, calling the people cattle for not having known. The villagers run after the two with gifts; Kokālika follows, ex-

pecting the frugal elders to refuse and the gifts to fall to him. They refuse, and do not pass them on. When they return with a great following and the gifts are shared among everyone but him, he reviles them as greedy; they leave; the villagers drive him out. He goes to the Buddha and three times accuses the two, and three times is told, "Say not so." As he leaves, boils the size of mustard seeds break out over his body and grow. His own former teacher, now a god, comes down to plead with him and is insulted in turn. He dies and falls into the Lotus hell. When the monks say that his tongue ruined him, the Buddha tells the birth story of the tortoise carried through the air on a stick by two geese. Read the full commentary story and the birth story of the talkative tortoise, a fable that also reached Europe as The Tortoise and the Birds.

Sharon Springs, New York

Sharon Springs, 1954

Sharon Springs, fifty miles west of Albany, was a sulphur spa from the 1820s. When Saratoga's hotels shut out Jews, German Jewish families came here instead; by the 1920s the guests were mostly Eastern European Jews, the white-columned sulphur temple and the Imperial Baths went up in 1927, and the Adler Hotel opened in 1929 with a hundred and fifty rooms and two kitchens. After the Second World War many of the summer people were Holocaust survivors, a good number of them Hasidic and Orthodox, taking the baths on doctors' orders. Small self-catering boardinghouses like Koppel's, called *kokhaleyns*, lined Main Street. The Imperial Baths closed in 2005.

The Rebbe of Hlinitz, his court on Hewes Street, and everyone on the street in Sharon Springs are invented. What is not invented is the teaching. The Talmud's tractate Arakhin (here in the old spelling, Erchin) is the classic source for the laws of *lashon hara*, harmful speech, and tradition ties slander to afflictions of the skin, as with Miriam in the Book of Numbers. Belief in the return of souls, *gilgul*, runs through Kabbalah and Hasidic storytelling, and the Rebbe tells the tortoise's fall in that key.

Both passages are quoted from *Hebraic Literature: Translations from the Talmud, Midrashim and Kabbala* (1901).

After the story of Kokālika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 363). The original. Talmud and Kabbalah passages from *Hebraic Literature: Translations from the Talmud, Midrashim and Kabbala* (1901). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.4

A Case of Grapefruit

> *And the children of Israel wept for Moses in the plains of Moab thirty days: so the days of weeping and mourning for Moses were ended.*
> — *Deuteronomy 34:8*

Here's how I heard it, on Bank Street.

I. Fourth of July

Bank Street, New London, Connecticut · March 2024

Royal Tate had tattooed on Bank Street since 1973, in a long narrow room between a bar and a shop that sold used anchors, and in all that time he had never put up a sign with his name on it. The sign said TATTOO. The window said TATTOO. People knew.

He had come to it sideways. He was a cook on submarines out of Groton in the sixties, a Black kid from Portsmouth, Virginia, who had gone into the Navy because his father had, and he had worn the silver dolphins and fed a hundred and twenty men in a galley the size of a closet. On leave in New York in 1965 he had gone looking for a tattoo and found that the city had outlawed them four years before. A man on a stoop sent him to a man in a back room on the Lower East Side, who did the work with the shades drawn, on a kitchen chair, and let Royal watch. Royal went back every leave for three years and swept the floor and watched. When he got out he knew how to build a coil machine from scratch and how to pull a line, and he knew that he would never do anything else.

The walls of the shop were flash from floor to ceiling, sheets of it in dime-store frames gone yellow: swallows, anchors, daggers through roses, panthers, hula girls, the Rock of Ages with a woman clinging to the cross

in a green sea, submarine dolphins in every size. Fifty years of men off the boats at the base had walked out of that room with those pictures on them, and their sons after them, and the welders from Electric Boat across the river, and lately a great many young women from Hartford who wanted the swallows on their collarbones and had found him on Instagram, where Royal had never been in his life.

On a Monday in March he came in from the oncologist at Lawrence and Memorial, hung his coat on the hook, and told the shop.

Pancreas, he said. *They give me about four months. Say the Fourth of July.*

Then he sat down at his station and finished the anchor he had started on a machinist from Ledyard that morning, because the man had only half an anchor.

II. The Line

April and May

THE SHOP FILLED UP AND STAYED FULL.

The apprentices and the two other artists came in on their days off and sat around his station. Old customers came in from Norwich and Mystic and Westerly with their sleeves rolled up to show him what he had done in 1979. Somebody put a vase of white roses on the counter by the register, and the next day there were three vases, and by May the counter was covered and the room smelled like a funeral parlor over the green soap. Men he had tattooed on the boats stood in the doorway and could not say anything and went next door to the bar. A woman from Groton brought a framed picture of her husband, dead twenty years, showing the eagle Royal had put on his back. Kevin, the senior apprentice, made a list of everyone who wanted to get one of Royal's own flash pieces from his hand before the Fourth, and the list went to four pages. Somebody started a hashtag. People slept in their cars on Bank Street to be first in line on Saturdays.

What are we going to do, Kevin kept saying, at night, when they were cleaning the stations. *What are we going to do after.*

Dominique Ruiz did not come in at all.

She was twenty-six. She had grown up on Hempstead Street four blocks away, and she had come into the shop at twenty-three with a sketchbook under her arm, and every other shop from New Haven to Providence had already told her no. Royal had looked at the sketchbook for a long time without saying anything. Then he had handed her a broom. For two years she had swept, cleaned tubes, mixed green soap, drawn flash and redrawn it, and watched. Six months ago he had let her start practicing on skin, pig skin from a butcher in Waterford, and then on fruit, and then on her own left leg. Her color was good and her shading was good. Her lines were not.

Your line has got a shake at the end of it, he had told her in January, holding a grapefruit up to the magnifier lamp. *Right here, at the tail, where you lift. You see it? That's you wanting it to be over. That's you thinking about the next one, and about who's going to see it. The line doesn't care who sees it.*

After the Monday in March she came in once. She stood at the back of the room behind the people with roses and did not go up to his station. Then she went home to her apartment over the laundromat on Bank Street and did not come back.

She had bought a case of grapefruit at the Stop & Shop. She set them in a row on the kitchen table under a gooseneck lamp, and she sat down with her liner, and she pulled one line on each grapefruit, around the curve, from one side to the other, a single line with no shape to it. Then the next. When the case was gone she bought another. In the evenings she drove to Waterford for pig skin. She did not draw anything. She did not post anything. She pulled lines until the muscle in her right forearm went hard as a broom handle and then she pulled more, and under the lamp she looked at the tail of every one.

When people from the shop texted her she did not answer. When they knocked she let them knock.

She hasn't come by once, Kevin told Royal in the middle of May. He said it at the station in front of everyone. *Not once, Royal. You took her in when nobody in New England would look at her, and you're sitting here dying and she can't walk four blocks. Marisol saw her at the Stop & Shop buying grapefruit. Grapefruit.*

Royal wiped down the station and did not say anything.

The next day he took out his phone, which he used only to call his sister in Portsmouth, and asked Kevin how you sent a message.

III. Four Blocks

June

She came in on a Tuesday after closing, with her kit in one hand and a grocery bag in the other. The roses had been cleared off the counter that morning by the cleaning woman, who could no longer stand it. Kevin and Marisol and the two artists were still there, and they stopped talking when she came in.

Royal was sitting in his own chair, the old red barber's chair at the first station, because he did not like the bed. He was thin now. His hands were the same.

They tell me you quit on me, he said. *Is it true?*

Yes, said Dom.

Why?

She put the grocery bag on the counter and did not take anything out of it.

You said four months, she said. *Everybody's in here getting your swallows. Everybody's crying. I can't do anything about the four months. And my line still shakes. You told me it shakes because I want it to be over, and because I'm thinking about who's going to see it. So I've been home pulling lines on grapefruit where nobody can see. I want to pull one straight before you go. While you can still look at it.*

Royal looked at her for a long time, the way he had looked at her sketchbook.

Good, he said. *Good.*

Then he turned the chair a little so he was facing the rest of them, Kevin and Marisol and the two artists, and the wall of flash, and the cleared counter where the roses had been.

Y'all have been good to me, he said. *I know it. But you're putting my roses on your arms and bringing roses in here, and that's flowers. You want to honor*

me, honor me like she's doing. Sit down and pull the line. He was quiet, and then he said, *My mother read us the part where Moses dies. They cried for him thirty days on the plains of Moab, and then the Lord shut it off. Get up. Go over. And then He told the young one what to do.*

He said it from memory, the way his mother had said it in the kitchen on Effingham Street, with the old King James words, and nobody in the shop moved.

> *This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.*
>
> *— Joshua 1:8*

Observe to do, said Royal. *Not observe to cry. Observe to do.*

Kevin looked at the floor. Marisol had her hand over her mouth. One of the artists got up and went to his station and opened a drawer, and took out a grapefruit he had been keeping there for a still life, and sat down with it.

IV. Dolphins

The first station · the same night

ROYAL ROLLED UP HIS LEFT SLEEVE.

On the inside of his forearm, among fifty years of pieces he had put on himself, were the dolphins he had put on himself in 1967 in a bunk on the boat, with a sewing needle and a bottle of India ink, the night he qualified. They had been the first thing he ever tattooed. They had gone soft and green and blurred the way homemade work does, and nobody had ever touched them, because he had never let anybody else put a needle in him.

Line them, he said. *Just the line. Go over mine.*

Dom set up her station on the counter where the roses had been. She bagged the machine and the cord. She poured the black into a cap and

wiped his arm down with green soap. He watched her do every bit of it as if she were being graded, which she was. Then she put her left hand flat on his arm to stretch the skin, the way he had shown her two years before with his hand over hers, and touched the needle down at the bow of the submarine where the dolphins' noses met.

The machine ran. Nobody in the shop said anything. Kevin had come up behind the chair and stood with his arms folded, and then he unfolded them.

She did not think about who was watching. She did not think about the Fourth of July. She thought about the line. It went where it went, along the curve of the hull, up the dolphins' backs and out along the tails. At the tail she lifted, and it did not shake.

She wiped it. Royal pulled the magnifier lamp over and looked at it for a long time.

He did not say anything. He reached over and took the grapefruit out of her grocery bag on the counter, the last one in the case, with a single black line around it from pole to pole, and he turned it in the light and set it next to his arm.

The new line sat on his forearm, blue-black and clean, laid exactly over the soft green one he had put there with a sewing needle in a bunk under the North Atlantic when he was twenty-one. Around it, all the way up to his elbow, the old work had faded the way it does, into the color of deep water.

Background

The verse

> *He who dwells in the law, delights in the law, meditates on the law, follows the law, that Bhikshu will never fall away from the true law.*
>
> Dhammapada 364, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha announces that in four months he will pass into final nirvana (parinibbāna). Thousands of monks crowd around him, weeping and asking each other what they will do. One monk, Dhammārāma, keeps away from them and will not say why. The others report that he has no love for the Teacher. Summoned,

Dhammārāma explains that he has not yet freed himself from desire and means to reach the goal while the Buddha is still alive, so he has gone off alone to reflect on and remember the teaching. The Buddha praises him: those who honor him with garlands and perfumes do not truly honor him, and those who practice the teaching do. At the end of the verse Dhammārāma becomes an arahant. Read the full commentary story.

New London, Connecticut

New London, 1961–2024

Across the Thames River from New London, Groton has been the Navy's submarine town since 1916, when the Naval Submarine Base New London became the first in the country. It calls itself the Home of the Submarine Force. Electric Boat builds submarines on the same shore. A sailor who completes the year-long qualification on a boat is designated "Qualified in Submarines" and wears the dolphins. Enlisted men have worn the silver pin since 1950. For a century the bars and tattoo shops along New London's waterfront served the men off the boats, and their shops were papered with flash, ready-made designs in black outline and a few colors, made for quick work on walk-in customers.

In 1961 New York City made it unlawful to tattoo a human being, citing a hepatitis outbreak that later critics said had nothing to do with tattooing. The ban held for thirty-six years. Tattooing went on behind drawn shades, and the city did not legalize it again until 1997 (the rise and fall of the ban). Apprenticeship is still the old way into the trade: years of sweeping, drawing and watching, then practice on fruit and on pig skin from the butcher, which comes closest to human skin for learning how deep the needle goes (how apprentices practice).

After the story of the Elder Dhammārāma from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 364). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

25.5

The Partition

*A small thing that the righteous hath, * is better than great riches of the ungodly.*
— Psalm 37:16, Book of Common Prayer (1928)

This is how it went around, at Twelve Corners.

I. The Plaza

Brighton, New York · Monday, January 25, 1971

Russ Hoyt ate his lunch in the car that day because he had shown the Bonesteel house at eleven and was showing it again at one, and there was no sense driving back to the office in between. He parked in the plaza lot at Twelve Corners with the heater running and unfolded the waxed paper on his knee. Liverwurst on rye, an apple, two of Jean's molasses cookies. He had sold houses for Thayer & Son for eight years, on a draw of a hundred and twenty-five dollars a week against commission. He had closed one sale since Thanksgiving.

A bronze Toronado pulled in nose to nose with his Rambler and Gary Spangler got out of it in a camel coat.

Gary had sat at the next desk for six of the eight years. In October Don Voss had walked out of Thayer's and taken four of the seven salesmen with him, and Gary was one of the four. Voss had been the best producer the firm ever had. He had gone in to Mr. Thayer after Labor Day and said that Mr. Thayer was sixty-one and ought to keep the insurance side and the name on the window and let a younger man run the selling the way selling was run now. Mr. Thayer had said no. That was all anybody at the front of the office heard of it.

Gary got in on the passenger side and looked at the sandwich.

Where've you been?

The Bonesteel house. Second time for the same people.

You getting anything to eat over there?

Russ held up the half he had left.

Come out to the Coachlight tonight, Gary said. *Prime rib. Every night this week, and Don buys. A full table closes better than a table with a hole in it, so we want the chairs filled. You wouldn't sell anything. You'd eat.*

I don't know about what you fellows are doing, Gary.

Nobody's asking you to know about it. Seven o'clock. Wear the blue suit.

II. The Coachlight

West Henrietta Road · Monday through Thursday

The land was called Ocotillo Mesa Estates and it was in New Mexico. Voss had the franchise for it from Syracuse to Buffalo. The invitations went out by mail, engraved, to lists he bought: men between forty-five and sixty with the house paid for, and above all Kodak men, because the company paid its wage dividend in March and every man in the plant had known since Christmas about what his would be.

There were twelve round tables in the banquet room of the Coachlight Inn, and at each one sat three couples and a closer. At Gary's table there were three couples, Gary, and Russ. A Manhattan came first. Then the prime rib, an inch thick and hanging over the plate, with a baked potato in foil and sour cream in a paper cup, and afterward a parfait in a tall glass. Russ ate all of it. He had not had beef like that since his wedding.

When the plates were cleared the lights went down for the film. It ran twenty-two minutes in color. A man in a yellow shirt drove a golf ball toward a mountain. A woman his age came up out of a swimming pool, laughing. There was a horse. Out the banquet room windows the snow was coming sideways off the lake across the parking lot, as it had been since the second week of November, and when the lights came up nobody in the room looked at the windows.

Then each closer opened a plat book on the tablecloth. A half-acre lot was two thousand nine hundred and ninety-five dollars, two ninety-five

down and thirty-four fifty a month. The government made the company hand out a gray pamphlet called a property report. Gary slid one to each husband with the plat on top of it and a pen beside it. *That's a receipt Washington wants,* he said. *Sign where the X is.* Every few minutes Voss called out from the microphone at the front. *Hold lot fourteen, block nine!* And a minute after that, *Lot fourteen is gone, folks.*

Russ here sells houses in Brighton, Gary said to the table. *Russ, what does land do?*

Generally it goes up, Russ said.

That was true in Brighton. It was the only thing he said about land at the Coachlight, and he said it once a night for four nights.

Afterward the closers went into the bar, and Voss stood the drinks, and Russ went with them because his coat was on the same rack. He had a second Manhattan and listened. It was shop talk, and it was nearly enough his own shop that he followed all of it.

You never let him carry the report home, a closer from Batavia said. *A man who reads is a man who doesn't buy.*

Get the wife to choose the lot, Gary said. *Once she's put her finger on one it's hers. Then if he wants to sleep on it, he's the one taking it away from her. You shut the book, you say that's fine, and you look at her like he hit her.*

Voss put it shortest. He stood at the end of the bar with his back to the snow.

Don't feel sorry for them. Sorry is an expensive habit. Every one of those people drove out here in a paid-for car to eat my roast beef for nothing. They came to take something off me. You go take something off them first.

Russ laughed when the others did. On Tuesday he came back, and on Wednesday. Jean packed his lunch the same as always, and he ate that too.

On Thursday the third couple at Gary's table were the Kimballs, from Antlers Drive. Art Kimball had thirty-one years in at Kodak Park. Thayer's had written the insurance on his house since before the war. Mrs. Kimball looked across the centerpiece and knew Russ at once.

Why, Art, it's Mr. Thayer's young man. Then it must be all right.

Russ cut his meat. Kimball said he would want to sleep on it. Gary shut the plat book and said that was fine, and turned and looked at Mrs. Kimball. Kimball took out his checkbook.

III. The Telephone

Thayer & Son, Monroe Avenue · Friday morning

Mrs. Bonesteel telephoned at half past nine. She was seventy-four and had been a widow since August. The couple who had seen the house twice had offered two thousand under what she asked, and she wanted to know from Russ whether she ought to wait for spring.

He meant to tell her what he would have told her any other week. What he said, tilted back in his chair with the cord across his chest, was that he had another party very much interested in a house on Elmwood, and that these people would not wait on her, and what did she suppose Mr. Bonesteel would have wanted her to do? There was a silence on the line. Then she said in a smaller voice that she supposed she had better sign.

He hung up pleased. A minute or so later he was less pleased, and could not have said why. There was no other party on Elmwood.

Miss Fitch sat at the front desk, eleven feet off. She had kept the books and the telephone at Thayer's for thirty-four years, and she heard everything said in that room whether she cared to or not. She had already taken one call that morning, from Mrs. Arthur Kimball, who wanted to ask in confidence whether Mr. Thayer had gone in with Mr. Voss on the New Mexico property, seeing that Mr. Hoyt had been at the table when Art signed. Miss Fitch finished the line she was typing. Then she went into Mr. Thayer's office and shut the door.

IV. Babyface

Mr. Thayer's office · five o'clock

Lyman Thayer was the Son on the window. He was a lay reader at his church and had read the lessons there for thirty years in a

VOICE THAT NEVER ROSE, AND PEOPLE WHO BOUGHT HOUSES from him sometimes said afterward that they could not remember his having sold them anything. Each day at five, when the telephones stopped, he took a Prayer Book out of the top drawer and read the psalms for the evening at his desk. The book was open in front of him when Russ came in.

Sit down, Russell. I am told you have been eating with Don Voss's people. Is that so?

Yes, sir. Four nights. Gary Spangler asked me. He's a friend of mine. Russ had spent the afternoon getting it ready. *I don't hold with what they're doing out there, Mr. Thayer. I never sold a lot. I never would. I ate the dinner.*

I will grant that you don't hold with it. Mr. Thayer looked at him without any heat. *But you go about, Russell, as though you held with whoever you happen to be sitting beside. Mrs. Kimball took it so last night. Mrs. Bonesteel would have taken it so this morning, if she had known who it was she was talking to.*

Russ had nothing ready for that.

This is the twenty-ninth, Mr. Thayer said. *These are the psalms for the twenty-ninth evening. I had read as far as this when you knocked.*

> *O let not mine heart be inclined to any evil thing; * let me not be occupied in ungodly works with the men that work wickedness, neither let me eat of such things as please them.*
>
> *— Psalm 141:4, Book of Common Prayer (1928)*

He let that stand a while. Then he told about Ed Mahler.

My father had a salesman in the twenties named Ed Mahler, whom everybody called Babyface. He was the gentlest man who ever sold a house in this county. He would walk a young couple through a place and tell them where the roof was going, and they would buy it from him anyway and send their cousins. In the fall of 1925 my father let the back room to two men up from Miami who were selling lots in Florida off a blueprint. You are too young to remember the Florida business. There was nothing between that room and ours but a beaverboard partition, and Ed's desk stood against it. He heard those two through the wall all day for six weeks. How you get the down payment before the man has

seen the ground. How a widow is the best prospect there is, because nobody is going to read the paper for her.

Ed never sold a lot of theirs. He told my father he did not believe a word either of them said. But by Christmas he had talked a streetcar man's widow on Meigs Street out of her house for nine hundred dollars under its worth, to a party he had an arrangement with. When my father asked him about it, he said that was how it was done now. He was short with the girl. He was short with me, and I was sixteen and only swept the place out on Saturdays. He had turned into those two men, and he did not know he had.

What did your father do?

He put the Florida men out on the sidewalk with their blueprint. He did not let Ed go. He moved Ed's desk up to the front, beside Mrs. Garlock, who kept the rent ledgers. She knew every tenant we had and all their children, and who was out of work and who had the croup, and she talked about them from eight until five to anyone within hearing. By the time the lilacs were out he was Babyface again. He sold for us for thirty years more. He never could tell you what had happened to him that winter.

Mr. Thayer turned the pages of the Prayer Book back toward the front.

This one belongs to the seventh evening. I do not think it will mind.

> *Fret not thyself because of the ungodly; * neither be thou envious against the evil doers.*
>
> *Put thou thy trust in the LORD, and be doing good; * dwell in the land, and verily thou shalt be fed.*
>
> *A small thing that the righteous hath, * is better than great riches of the ungodly.*
>
> *— Psalm 37:1, 3, 16, Book of Common Prayer (1928)*

You will see a star in the middle of every verse, he said. *That is where the reader stops for a breath. My father used to say the whole of this business was in the star.* He closed the book and put it in the drawer. *You have a wife who packs you a lunch, and a desk here, and a hundred and twenty-five a week in the worst month of the year. It is not prime rib. I would not look down on it. Go home, Russell.*

V. The Front

Monroe Avenue · Monday, February 1

On Saturday morning Russ drove to Antlers Drive with a gray pamphlet he had carried out of the Coachlight in his coat pocket, and sat in the Kimballs' kitchen, and read them the page about water. There was no water. There was no power to the block the plat had shown them, or any date for it. Art Kimball's check had gone to Syracuse in Friday's mail. It took him until June, and a letter from Mr. Thayer's lawyer, to get it back.

On Monday Russ telephoned Mrs. Bonesteel before he took off his overshoes. He told her that there had not been any party on Elmwood. He told her the offer she had was a winter offer. If it were his mother's house he would take the sign down and put it up again the second week of May, when the lilac hedge along her drive came out and did the selling for her. She said she was glad, because she had not slept. It put his commission off until summer, if it came to him at all.

His desk had been moved over the weekend. Nobody mentioned it. It stood at the front now, at a right angle to Miss Fitch's, near enough that their wastebaskets touched.

At noon he unfolded the waxed paper on his blotter. Liverwurst on rye, an apple, two molasses cookies. Miss Fitch was on the telephone with a tenant on Clover Street whose pipes had frozen. She told the tenant that it was the same pipe as last year and the year before, and that the man they wanted was Lou DiNardo and not his brother, and she asked how the mother was getting on with the new hip. Without turning around she tore her slice of date-nut bread in two and put half of it on a napkin at the corner of his blotter.

There was no partition at the front. He ate his lunch and heard every word.

Background

The verses

> *Let him not despise what he has received, nor ever envy others: a mendicant who envies others does not obtain peace of mind.*
>
> Dhammapada 365, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *A Bhikshu who, though he receives little, does not despise what he has received, even the gods will praise him, if his life is pure, and if he is not slothful.*
>
> Dhammapada 366, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary a bhikkhu coming back from his almsround meets a friend who has gone over to Devadatta, the cousin who tried to take the Saṅgha from the Buddha and then split it. The friend asks whether he got anything to eat and says: here we receive rich offerings, stay with us a while. He stays several days. Reported and summoned, he answers that he does not share Devadatta's views, and the Buddha replies that even so he roves about as though he held the views of everyone he meets. The Buddha then tells the birth story of the gentle state elephant Mahilāmukha, "Damsel-Face," who overheard burglars talking by his stall night after night, took their talk for instruction and began killing his keepers, and who was cured when good men were set to talk of kindness within his hearing. Read the full commentary story.

Brighton (Rochester), New York

Rochester, 1971

In the 1960s and early 1970s a handful of companies sold raw desert lots by the tens of thousands in New Mexico, Arizona and Florida to people in the Northeast and Midwest who had never seen them. The standard method was the free dinner: an invitation by mail, a meal at a hotel or restaurant, a color film of the good life in the sun, and a salesman at every table. The best known of these developments was Rio

Rancho, whose developer, the Amrep Corporation, was later convicted of fraud. Congress had answered the trade in 1968 with the Interstate Land Sales Full Disclosure Act, which required a printed property report to be given to every buyer; salesmen learned to present it as a receipt. Ocotillo Mesa Estates, the Coachlight Inn, Thayer & Son and everyone in them are invented. Mr. Thayer's story of 1925 remembers an earlier round of the same business, the Florida land boom, when Florida lots were sold sight unseen to northerners.

Brighton is an old suburb on the southeast edge of Rochester; Twelve Corners is its crossroads. Rochester was then a company town for Eastman Kodak, which since 1912 had paid its workers a yearly "wage dividend," known locally as the Kodak bonus and paid in March. The city is also known for the lilacs of Highland Park, which bloom in the middle of May. The psalms are from the Psalter of the 1928 American Book of Common Prayer, which divides the hundred and fifty psalms over the mornings and evenings of a thirty-day month. Psalm 141 falls on the twenty-ninth evening and Psalm 37 on the seventh. The asterisk in each verse marks the pause for chanting.

After the story of the treacherous bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 365 and 366). The original. Scripture from the Psalter of the Book of Common Prayer (1928). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.6

In the Boy's Name

In it there is nothing which is thine, Nanak preacheth.
— Guru Teg Bahadur, Slok XLI

Así me lo contaron, on the Holtville side of the Alamo River.

I. Primicias

East of Holtville, Imperial Valley · 1921 to 1933

Inder Singh came down to the Valley in 1913 with a gang of men from Jullundur to pick cotton, and stayed to grow it. By 1921 he had cut his hair, leveled eighty acres under the East Highline Canal with four mules and a Fresno scraper, and married Guadalupe Robles of Sonora, whose older sister had married his partner the spring before. The Mexicans on the place called him Andrés. The Anglos in town called him Andy, and called him and every man like him a Hindu, though he was a Sikh and had told them so.

He grew cotton for the bank. For the house he kept an acre along the head ditch in corn, melons, okra, chiles, and in winter the mustard greens of his own country, and it was that acre people talked about.

When the first of anything came ripe in it, he picked it and carried it out to the road and gave it to whoever came along. When he loaded the wagon for town, the first crate went off the tailgate at the first tent he passed. When he brought home the hundred-pound sack of flour, the first scoop out of it went down to the pickers' camp in a lard pail before the sack was leaned in its corner. When Lupe cooked, the first ladle out of the pot went out the kitchen door. And when his plate was in front of him he looked around the room and out into the yard for anybody at all, a child, a hired man, the ditch tender on his horse, and gave off the plate

before he lifted his hand to it. Five times between the dirt and his mouth. He did not taste a thing until all five were done.

Lupe had been taught her catechism by a grandmother in Ures, and the fifth commandment of the Church was to pay tithes and first fruits. *Primicias,* she told him. *God asks it once. Once, Andrés, and He is God.*

Then four are from me, he said.

So the camps called him Don Primicias, and children learned to be standing in his yard at noon.

He was easy about food. He was not easy about the eighty acres. Since 1923, when the high court in Washington said that a man from India could not be a citizen, the land law of California had applied to him, and a man who could not be a citizen could not own a furrow or lease one. So the lease was written to Mr. Varney, a director of the bank in Holtville that people called the Hindu Bank because of how much ground its officers held this way, for how many men. Mr. Varney was honest. At Christmas Andrés took him two live hens.

Then in May of 1933 a grand jury sat in El Centro, and four of his countrymen were tried there with their Anglo partners for conspiring to get around the land law. By the end of summer three of the four were in San Quentin. Mr. Varney stopped coming out to look at the cotton. The lawyer in Brawley said there was one safe way left. The boy, Jesús, was seven and had been born at Holtville, and nobody could say he was not a citizen. Put everything in the boy's name. The father would stand as guardian and go before the judge once a year with his accounts.

Andrés had not slept a whole night since May. He walked the head ditch in the dark with the papers going around in him. Twenty years of his back were in that ground, and his name was nowhere on it, and now it would be on it even less.

II. The Door

The kitchen · a noon in late October 1933

THEY WERE PICKING. HE HAD BEEN AT THE SCALE SINCE BEfore light, and at noon he came in and sat down at the table with his back

TO THE DOOR, THE WAY HE ALWAYS SAT, BECAUSE THE GLARE off the yard hurt his eyes. Lupe set the plate down: chicken curry the way he had taught her, beans, and four rotis off the comal, which she made of his flour and went on calling tortillas.

The first of the garden had gone to the road in June. The first of the wagon had gone, and the first of the sack. The first of this pot had gone out to the weigh crew an hour ago, and the rest of the pot after it, because there were more of them than she had counted on. He looked around the kitchen for the fifth. The boy was at school. The yard, when he turned his head, had only chickens in it. He waited a little, and then he tore a roti and began.

He had eaten half the plate when the old man came to the door.

Everybody under the Highline knew him. He had come to California before any of them, and worked the railroad grades in the north, and somewhere along the way had let go of working for wages or for shares. He had no lease and no partner and no banker. He walked the canal banks from Calexico to Niland with a blanket over his shoulder and a brass bowl, in a turban washed so often it had gone the color of the sky at the edges, and he ate what he was given and did not ask for it. The men called him Baba. He came and stood, and if nothing was brought he went on.

Lupe saw him through the screen. She knew to the spoonful what was left in her kitchen, and it was on that plate. She knew her husband had been thin since May. If he turned his head now, he would be up out of the chair with the plate in his hands, and she would have nothing to put in front of him but beans.

So she stepped between them. She stood behind his chair with her back to the door and bent over him, moving the salt, spreading her elbows, a small woman trying to be as wide as a doorway. She might as well have held up her hand to cover the moon. She kept half an eye over her shoulder. *Has he gone?* He had not gone. She did not dare tell him to, because Andrés would hear.

When she could not stand it she backed up to the screen and said through her teeth, not turning around, *Ándele. Pase.*

The old man looked at her. Then he shook his head, slowly, side to side, with his lips shut, exactly the way Jesús did when she came at him with the castor oil.

It was the beard that did it. A white beard down to the middle of his chest, going left and right. The laugh came up out of her before she could get her apron over it, the kind of laugh that comes in church.

This is the part they tell carefully. As she laughed, light came in at the door past her and lay on the whitewashed wall in front of Andrés, where no light fell at that hour. It was not the white of the yard. It was blue, and yellow, and red, and a white cleaner than the wall, and the orange of a turban on a feast day, lying together like oil on ditch water, and it had the shape of a man standing.

He heard his wife laugh and saw the wall, both at once, and turned around.

Woman, I am ruined, he said. *He was at my door and you let me eat.*

III. The Second Half

The same noon

HE CARRIED THE PLATE TO THE DOOR AND PUSHED THE SCREEN open with his foot.

Baba ji. I gave the first of the garden and the first of the wagon and the first of the sack and the first of the pot, and then I looked for someone and saw no one, and I sat down. I have eaten half of this. My hand has been in it. It is all there is in the house. Will you take it from me?

Any other holy man he had ever met would have looked at a half-eaten plate and remembered somewhere he had to be.

The first of the pot is good, the old man said. *The middle of the pot is good. What is left on the plate is good.* He said the next thing in Spanish, so that she would have it too. *I am like the dead, hija. I eat what was set out for somebody else.*

Lupe, who in a week would be laying bread and salt on a table for her mother and her two brothers, stopped laughing.

He took the plate in both hands, and said over it a couplet of Farid's that every man from that country knew.

Eat hard dry bread, and drink cold water;
Farid, on seeing another's buttered bread let not thy heart long for it.

— Farid, Slok XXIX

Andrés stood in his own doorway and was gladder than the five gifts had ever made him. He had given the top of everything for twelve years and been pleased with himself for it, and here was a man to whom the top and the bottom were one plate.

Baba ji, he said. *At home they would call you a faqir. Here they call you a tramp, and me a Hindu, and my cotton Mr. Varney's. What does a man have to be, to be rightly called what you are?*

The old man looked past him at the field, where the pickers had gone back down the rows with their long sacks dragging.

Whose land?

Mr. Varney's, on the paper. Next month my son's.

The county did that to shame you. The county does not know what it has shown you. Go on with it. This Andrés, this Inder Singh, this Hindu. This back that leveled the ground. Look for the paper with your name on it for those. When a man has looked everywhere and found no such paper, and does not go up and down the ditch at night crying for a thing that was never in the drawer, call him a faqir. He need not walk the canal.

Then he said two of the Ninth Guru's sloks, the ones read at the close, when the Book has been gone through to the end.

Why entertainest thou false pride? Know that the world is like a dream;
In it there is nothing which is thine, Nanak preacheth.

Be anxious only regarding what is not expected;
It is the way of the world, Nanak, that nothing is permanent.

— Guru Teg Bahadur, Sloks XLI and LI

Andrés had heard those lines as a boy, sitting on a swept floor behind his father, when they meant that the reading was over and there would be something sweet. Lupe had no Punjabi beyond the names of spices. But her grandmother in Ures had said one word over every broken dish and every grave, *prestado,* lent, and she heard the old man say it now in his own language as plainly as if he had said it in hers.

Neither of them could have told you afterward how long they stood there. The thing that had walked Andrés up and down the ditch since May was not in him. He looked for it, the way you feel for a tooth, and there was the place where it had been.

The old man sat down on the step and ate the half plate to the last bean. He washed the plate at the pump, and his bowl, and set the plate on the step, and went north along the canal bank.

IV. In the Boy's Name

El Centro · November 1933, and after

The lawyer from Brawley had seen a good many of these men sign, that fall, and knew the look they wore doing it. Andrés signed as guardian of the estate of Jesús Inder Singh, a minor, the way a man signs for a crate at the depot that is addressed to somebody else. Then he asked the clerk where a person could get a cold drink.

Once a year he put on a clean shirt and went before the judge with his accounts. He slept. He went on giving the five firsts, since there was no reason to stop, and Lupe went on telling him God asked for one. She cooked one roti over the count every noon from then on, and never mentioned it.

The law changed in 1946, and in 1949 he raised his right hand in the same courthouse and came out a citizen. The lawyer, an old man himself by then, asked whether he wanted the eighty acres moved over into his own name at last. Jesús was twenty-three and running the place.

Leave it, Andrés said.

He had turned his chair around that October. For the rest of his life he ate his noon meal facing the door, with the glare in his eyes and the plate set a little toward the edge of the table.

Background

The verse

> *He who never identifies himself with name and form, and does not grieve over what is no more, he indeed is called a Bhikshu.*
>
> Dhammapada 367, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin of Sāvatthī gives the first of his crop five times over: from the field, the threshing floor, the storehouse, the pot and the dish. He is called Pañcaggadāyaka, Giver of the Five First-Fruits. One day the Buddha stands at his door while he eats with his back to it. His wife, afraid he will give his dinner away, tries to hide the visitor and whispers to him to pass on; the Buddha shakes his head, she laughs aloud, a radiance falls into the house, and the Brahmin turns. He offers the half he has not eaten. The Buddha accepts it, saying that first, middle or last portion are all fit for one who lives on what others give, "like the petas," the hungry dead. Asked what makes a bhikkhu, he speaks the verse on name-and-form, and husband and wife are both established in the path. Read the full commentary story, or about name-and-form (nāmarūpa).

Holtville, California

The Imperial Valley, 1933

Punjabi men, most of them Sikhs, came to California's farm valleys from about 1907. Immigration law kept their families in India, and California law barred them from marrying white women, so several hundred married women of Mexican descent, of-

ten sisters marrying partners. Their households cooked chicken curry and roti beside beans and tortillas, spoke Spanish and English, and baptized their children Catholic. See Punjabi Mexican Americans and the University of California, Davis, archive on the hard years of 1923 to 1945. The nearest gurdwara was the one founded at Stockton in 1912, some five hundred miles north.

After *United States v. Bhagat Singh Thind* (1923) held Indians ineligible for citizenship, the California Alien Land Law barred them from owning or leasing farmland. They farmed on through verbal understandings with Anglo bankers, lawyers and farmers; a Holtville bank whose director held land for Punjabi clients was known as the "Hindu Bank." In May 1933 an Imperial County grand jury brought a conspiracy case against four Punjabi farmers and their Anglo partners; the four were convicted, and three were sent to San Quentin before an appeals court ordered a new trial in 1934 that was never held. From 1933 on, most Punjabi farmers in the county registered as guardians of their American-born children and held the land in the children's names, as the historian Karen Leonard documented in "Punjabi Farmers and California's Alien Land Law". The Luce–Celler Act of 1946 opened citizenship to them. The verses are from Shaikh Farid and Guru Teg Bahadur in the Sikh scripture; the Ninth Guru's sloks are read at the conclusion of a complete reading of the Guru Granth Sahib. Andrés, Lupe, Mr. Varney and the old man are invented.

After the story of the Brahmin Pañcaggadāyaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 367). The original. Scripture from the Guru Granth Sahib, translated by Max Arthur Macauliffe in *The Sikh Religion* (1909). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.7

Red Clay

> *Therefore let one always be thoughtful, and avoid pleasures; having abandoned them, let him cross the stream, after baling out the ship, and go to the other shore.*
> — *Sutta-Nipāta 771*

Khaphachao dai sadap ma laeo yang ni, in the base town under the Sacramentos.

I. The Earring

Alamogordo, New Mexico · spring 1981

Kalaya Whitlock had come from Udon Thani in 1965 as the wife of an Air Force crew chief, with a baby not yet walking and two suitcases, and had buried the crew chief in 1975. By 1981 she owned the Siam Kitchen on White Sands Boulevard, the building it was in, and the two buildings beside it. She did not trust the bank with more than the mortgage. What she made she turned into gold, in chains, by weight, the way her mother had, and wore some of it and kept the rest at home.

Her son was seventeen and was called Sonny by everyone, including her. He bussed tables, played second base badly for the Tigers, and wore in his left ear a gold stud his mother had given him when he was twelve, which got him into two fights a year. He was the only boy in Otero County who went to the temple without being driven.

The temple was a three-bedroom house on a gravel street near the railroad, bought by eleven Thai wives who had put in forty dollars a month apiece. It had one monk. Ajahn Thongdee was past sixty and had been sent out from Bangkok, and it was said of him that he could take four words of the Buddha's and talk on them until the ice was gone from

everybody's tea, and that when he was done you understood the four words. Sonny sat through all of it. In April he asked to be ordained.

Sonny, the Ajahn said, *one meal a day. A bed by yourself for the rest of your life. No girl, ever. It is hard to do in Thailand, where everyone helps you. Here nobody will even know what you are. Go finish school.*

He asked again in May, and the Ajahn said the same thing in more words.

In June, the week after graduation, he asked a third time, and the Ajahn looked at him a while and sent him to get his mother.

They shaved his head on the carport. Kalaya cut the first lock herself and caught it in a lotus leaf she had made out of a green paper plate, since there were no lotuses. He took the earring out before he knelt and put it in her hand. He was a novice by noon, in a robe that had come in the mail from Los Angeles, and the Ajahn wrote his new name on a slip of paper and showed it to her. *Sono.*

So you will not have to learn another one, he said.

II. Ten Monks

Alamogordo · 1981 *to* 1984

A NOVICE CAN BE MADE BY ONE MONK. A MONK CANNOT. By the rule as the Ajahn had always kept it, the full ordination wants ten, sitting together inside a marked boundary, and in 1981 there were not ten Thai monks between El Paso and Denver. So the novice Sōno swept the gravel, carried the bowl behind his teacher down a street where the only people who came out were the eleven wives, and learned.

The Ajahn taught him the way he had been taught, by ear. He gave him the Chapter of the Eights, sixteen old poems out of the Sutta Nipāta, a line at a time, in Pāli, until the boy could chant all sixteen from the first word to the last without a book, and then he made him say what every line meant, in Thai and in English. It took most of three years. It was three years also before ten monks could be got into Otero County on one day, by car from Denver and Houston and by air from California, and

Kalaya fed all ten. Sōno was twenty that spring. They ordained him in the back yard, inside eight stones.

That summer the Ajahn sent him west. A very old monk from the forest monasteries of the northeast, Luang Pu Kham, whom the Ajahn had bowed to as a young man, was spending the rains at the Thai temple in North Hollywood. *Go and see what one looks like,* the Ajahn said. *And ask him something for me.* He told him the questions twice, and then put him on the bus.

III. Sadhu

Wat Thai, North Hollywood · July 1984

It is eight hundred miles, most of it desert. The old man received him as if he had come from across the street. He asked whether the road had been hard, whether he had eaten, how his teacher's knees were. Then, in front of forty monks who had been waiting weeks for ten minutes with him, he told the attendants to lay a second mat in his own room for the young monk from New Mexico.

Sōno could not make himself go in. He walked up and down the temple yard under the big tiled roof most of the night, and went in at last and sat on the mat, and did not sleep much.

Before light the old man was sitting up.

Your teacher taught you something, he said. *Let me hear it.*

So Sōno chanted the Chapter of the Eights, in that small room, to one listener, while the window went grey. All sixteen, from the poem on desire to the poem Sāriputta asks for at the end. He did not drop a syllable. When the last line had gone out of the room, the old man said:

Sadhu. Sadhu, bhikkhu. Well said. You have it whole.

The Thai people in Los Angeles tell the next part. They say that when Luang Pu Kham said *sadhu* that morning, something took it up outside. The spirit of the ground the temple stood on said it, and the ones in the pepper trees on Coldwater Canyon, and the ones in the air over them, and so on up, a long way, the way a cheer goes up the rows of a stadium.

Then Sōno remembered his errand. *Luang Pu, my teacher asks. Out where we are, it took three years to find ten monks. Could five do, for an ordination, one of them knowing the rule? And the ground is all thorns and hot rock. May a monk wear thick soles? And the dust. May we bathe every day?*

The old man laughed until he had to wipe his eyes.

Tell Thongdee to read his own books. A monk came to the Buddha once from the border country, with those same questions from his teacher, and the Buddha said yes to every one. Five is enough at the edge of things. Thick soles. Bathe. He looked at Sōno. *That monk had just finished chanting the Eights.*

IV. The Spirit House

Alamogordo · the same morning

Kalaya's house stood at the east edge of town where the streets give out toward the mountains. In the corner of the yard, on a post, where the shadow of the roof never fell on it, was the spirit house: a little red-and-gold temple the size of a birdhouse, for the one the ground had belonged to before she bought it. Every morning she put out rice, a glass of water, and whatever was in flower.

She was setting down the glass when somebody clapped. Two hands, close by, and a voice. *Sadhu!*

Who is that? said Kalaya.

It's me, sister.

Who is me?

The one who lives in your yard.

She looked at the little house. *Twenty years I bring you rice,* she said, *and you never clapped for me once.*

I am not clapping for you.

Then for who?

For your son. This morning in the old teacher's own room he chanted the Dhamma, and the old teacher said sadhu. Then all of us said it. I only said it last.

Wait, said Kalaya. *My son chanted to the teacher? The teacher did not chant to my son?*

Your son to the teacher.

She stood in the yard with the rice spoon in her hand, and the gladness went through her from the feet up, five kinds of it, she said later, one after another. Then she thought: if he can chant it to that old man, he can chant it to me.

When Sōno came home on the bus she fed the Ajahn and him, and then she asked him straight out whether it was true. He asked who had told her. She told him. He did not argue with it.

Then Saturday week, she said, *you will sit in the chair and I will sit on the floor, and you will give me all of it.*

V. Copper, Silver, Gold

Alamogordo · a Saturday night in August 1984

The temple's front room held thirty people, so Kalaya rented the VFW hall. She hung it with marigolds. She borrowed an armchair from a furniture store and covered it with gold cloth for the preaching seat. She closed the restaurant and brought every person who worked for her except Teresa Montoya, who waited tables and was nineteen, and whom she left at the house.

The house needed somebody. It had a block wall around it with bottle glass set in the top, an iron gate, bars on the windows, and two Dobermans on run wires. The driveway was tarred, soft by day and hard at night, so that anybody who crossed it in the afternoon left his shoe size. In the floor of the back bedroom, under a rug, was a safe set in a yard of concrete. All of this was known up and down Highway 54, and for two years a crew of nine men out of El Paso, who worked the base towns, had been driving past it slowly. Their trouble had never been the wall. It was that she was always home.

That night they watched her car go. They dug under the wall on the arroyo side, where the caliche was rotten, and came up inside. What they did about the dogs is not told. The dogs were all right in the morning.

The one who ran the crew was called Dub. He sent himself to the hall. *If she gets word and starts for home,* he told them, *I'll see she doesn't get there.*

He had a pistol under his jacket, and he meant it. There were American husbands on folding chairs along the back, so nobody looked twice at one more. He took the chair directly behind the place where she sat on the floor with her feet tucked to one side and her hands together.

At eight Sōno came in behind the Ajahn, bowed three times to the Buddha on the card table, and climbed into the armchair. He chanted the first poem in Pāli. Then he said it over in Thai, and then, for the husbands and the kids, in English.

> *He who covets extensively (such) pleasures (as these), fields, goods, or gold, cows and horses, servants, women, relations,*
>
> *Sins will overpower him, dangers will crush him, and pain will follow him as water (pours into) a broken ship.*
>
> *Therefore let one always be thoughtful, and avoid pleasures; having abandoned them, let him cross the stream, after baling out the ship, and go to the other shore.*
>
> *— Sutta-Nipāta 769–771 (Kāmasutta)*

He was partway into the second when Teresa came in the side door, out of breath, and got down on her knees beside Kalaya.

Mrs. Whitlock. There's men in the house. A lot of men. They've got the closet open where you keep the coffee cans.

That was ten years of restaurant pennies, in Folgers cans, floor to shelf.

Let them take the pennies, Kalaya said, not turning her head. *I am listening to my son. Don't spoil it for me. Go home.*

Teresa went. She got as far as the gate and looked in, and came back. It was the fifth poem by then.

Mrs. Whitlock, they're in the dining room. They've got the silver bowls. They've got your mother's belt.

Let them take what they want. Don't spoil it. Go home.

The third time it was past midnight, and Teresa was crying. *They pulled up the rug. They're in the floor.*

Kalaya turned around then. *Teresa. Two times you came and two times I told you. Let them take it. I am hearing the Dhamma from my son's mouth, and you come and come. If you come one more time I will do something about you. Go home.*

She turned back, put her hands together, and found her place.

Dub had heard all three, from two feet off. He sat a minute longer. He had robbed people who begged and people who fought and one who had prayed out loud at him, and he had never before been in a room with someone who had weighed the whole of what she owned against what a boy in a chair was saying, and had not needed to think about it.

He went out the side door and drove to the house.

Put it back, he told them. *All of it. If we carry this woman's stuff out of here, lightning is going to come down and split our heads, and I for one will have it coming.*

They put the chains back in the floor by weight, the way they had come out. They set the bowls on the sideboard and the belt in its drawer. They carried the Folgers cans back to the closet and stacked them, and one of them picked a penny out of the carpet and dropped it in. Then all nine drove to the VFW hall and stood along the back wall in their work clothes, and stayed there until the windows were light and the sixteenth poem was done.

Ajahn Thongdee said afterward that he had been reading a line for forty years, that the Dhamma looks after the one who keeps it, and had taken it for a manner of speaking.

VI. Red Clay

Alamogordo and La Luz · autumn 1984

WHEN SŌNO CAME DOWN FROM THE CHAIR, A BIG MAN GOT ON his knees in front of Kalaya and put his forehead on the linoleum.

Ma'am, I need you to pardon me.

For what?

I sat behind you all night with a gun. If you'd got up to go home I was going to kill you.

All right, said Kalaya. *I pardon you.*

The other eight came up one at a time and said what they had done, and she pardoned each of them in the same four words. Then Dub said: *If you mean that, ask him if he'll take us. Whatever he is. We want to be it.*

She turned to her son and put her hands together, as a laywoman does to a monk. *Venerable sir, these men liked the way I listened and the way you chanted. They want to go forth. Let them.*

There were not nine robes in New Mexico. They tore Kalaya's bedsheets to the measure, and Sōno dyed them in a washtub with red clay out of the arroyo behind the temple, and they dried on the chain-link the color of the hills. The Ajahn shaved nine heads on the carport and made nine novices. And when, that October, five monks could be got together in one back yard, he read them the old teacher's answer out of his own book, with his finger on the line, and ordained all nine.

Sōno gave each man one thing to work at, a different thing for each, the way his teacher had done for him. They went up into the foothills above La Luz, where the juniper and piñon begin, and each man picked a tree and sat down under it.

This is told two ways, and the two agree. In North Hollywood the attendants say that one afternoon Luang Pu Kham stopped in the middle of his tea and sat looking east for some time, and moved his lips. And each of the nine said afterward that the old man had been sitting in front of him, under his own tree, close enough to touch, and had spoken to him alone, in English, or in the case of two of them in Spanish.

To the first he said that a man who lives in kindness, and is glad of the teaching, comes to the quiet place. To Dub he said: *Bail the boat. You heard it in the hall. It goes light when it's empty.* To the third he counted on his fingers, five to cut, five to leave, five to grow, and five more to get past, and then you are over the flood. To the fourth: *Sit, and do not be careless. Do not swallow the hot iron and then cry that it burns.* To the fifth, that there is no stillness without understanding and no understanding without stillness, and the one with both is near. To the sixth, that a monk who goes into an empty house with his mind quiet has a gladness that is not of this world. To the seventh, that each time he sees a thing rise and

fall away, there is joy in it, and that seeing is what does not die. And to the last two, who were the youngest, he gave the beginning of it: watch the doors of the senses, be content, keep the rule, keep good friends. What he said to the first man and to those last two is in the old book the Eights come from, nearly word for word.

> *And let him cultivate goodwill towards all the world, a boundless (friendly) mind, above and below and across, unobstructed, without hatred, without enmity.*
>
> *— Sutta-Nipāta 149 (Mettasutta)*
>
> *Cultivate (the society of) virtuous friends and a distant dwelling-place, secluded and quiet; be moderate in food.*
>
> *Be subdued according to the precepts, and as to the five senses, be attentive as regards thy body, and be full of disgust (with the world).*
>
> *— Sutta-Nipāta 337, 339 (Rāhulasutta)*

Each man, they say, was finished as his own line ended. Nobody saw them come down the hill. That evening there were nine monks nobody knew at the chanting in North Hollywood, eight hundred miles across the desert, in robes the color of New Mexico, with thick-soled sandals lined up at the door. The bus takes seventeen hours. They bowed at the old man's feet, and he asked whether the road had been hard.

• • •

Kalaya went on putting out the rice. The spirit house did not clap again, and she did not expect it to. Her son's earring she had melted into the next chain.

The hole under the wall on the arroyo side she never had filled. The dogs went in and out by it for years.

Background

The verses

The Bhikshu who acts with kindness, who is calm in the doctrine of Buddha, will reach the quiet place (Nirvana), cessation of natural desires, and happiness.

Dhammapada 368, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

O Bhikshu, empty this boat! if emptied, it will go quickly; having cut off passion and hatred thou wilt go to Nirvana.

Dhammapada 369, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Cut off the five (senses), leave the five, rise above the five. A Bhikshu, who has escaped from the five fetters, he is called Oghatinna, `saved from the flood.'

Dhammapada 370, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Meditate, O Bhikshu, and be not heedless! Do not direct thy thought to what gives pleasure that thou mayest not for thy heedlessness have to swallow the iron ball (in hell), and that thou mayest not cry out when burning, `This is pain.'

Dhammapada 371, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Without knowledge there is no meditation, without meditation there is no knowledge: he who has knowledge and meditation is near unto Nirvana.

Dhammapada 372, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

A Bhikshu who has entered his empty house, and whose mind is tranquil, feels a more than human delight when he sees the law clearly.

Dhammapada 373, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

As soon as he has considered the origin and destruction of the elements (khandha) of the body, he finds happiness and joy which belong to those who know the immortal (Nirvana).

Dhammapada 374, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

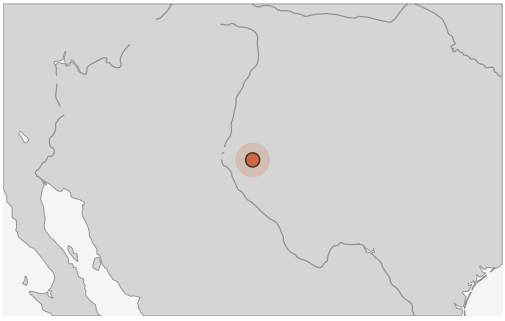
And this is the beginning here for a wise Bhikshu: watchfulness over the senses, contentedness, restraint under the law; keep noble friends whose life is pure, and who are not slothful.

Dhammapada 375, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Let him live in charity, let him be perfect in his duties; then in the fulness of delight he will make an end of suffering.

Dhammapada 376, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Soṇa Kuṭikaṇṇa ("Soṇa of the costly earring") lives in Avanti, far to the southwest, where monks are few. The elder Mahā Kaccāna twice refuses to ordain him, warning how hard it is to eat alone, sleep alone and stay celibate, and it takes three years to gather the ten monks his full ordination needs. He travels to the Buddha, shares his room, and at dawn intones the whole Chapter of the Eights; the Buddha's "Well done" is taken up by the gods, and the spirit in his mother's house, 120 leagues away, applauds. He then asks, for his teacher, that five monks may ordain in the border countries. His mother arranges to hear him preach, and when her maid comes three times to say that thieves are emptying her copper room, her silver room and her gold room, she will not leave the sermon. The thieves' leader, posted beside her to kill her, has everything put back; nine hundred thieves ask her pardon, are ordained in cloth dyed with red clay, and sit each under his own tree on a mountain, where the Buddha appears to them and speaks these nine verses. They cross the desert through the air to bow at his feet. Read the full commentary story. The poems Soṇa chants survive as the Aṭṭhakavagga of the Sutta Nipāta; the first of them, on desire, already tells the hearer to bale out the ship.



Alamogordo, New Mexico

A base town, 1984

During the Vietnam War tens of thousands of American airmen were stationed at bases in Thailand such as Udorn and Takhli, and many came home with Thai wives. Those women, scattered among Air Force towns across the United States, were among the first Thai Americans, and in a number of places they pooled their money to buy a house and bring a monk to live in it. Holloman Air Force Base lies just outside Alamogordo, under the Sacramento Mountains; the village of La Luz is immediately north. The house-temple in the story, its monk, the Whitlocks and the crew from El Paso are invented.

Wat Thai of Los Angeles, in North Hollywood, began in a house in 1971; its Thai-style main hall was consecrated in 1982, and it is generally counted the first Thai temple in the United States. Luang Pu Kham, a monk of the Thai Forest Tradition, is

invented. A boy can become a novice under a single monk, but full ordination, not given before the age of twenty, needs a chapter of ten monks, or five in outlying regions, an allowance the monastic code traces to Soṇa's errand, along with thick-soled sandals and frequent bathing. A spirit house for the guardian of the land, the *phra phum*, stands in the yard of most Thai homes; the commentary's first applauding gods are the *bhummaṭṭhaka*, the ones who live on the ground.

After the story of a company of bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 368–376). The original. Scripture from the Sutta-Nipāta, translated by V. Fausböll (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 10, 1881). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.8

Before the Blue Is Down

> *Lord judge, here I pluck a flower; if you can burn this flower and me, you have justly condemned me.*
> *— Leonhard Keyser, 1527, in the Martyrs Mirror*

The way we tell it, on the James River.

I. Five O'Clock

A colony on the James River, South Dakota · Tuesday, July 16, 1918

We are one people, so we tell it as one. The bell rang at five on its post by the kitchen, the way it had rung every morning since our grandfathers set the post in 1874, and we got up, a hundred and nineteen of us, and washed, and the men went out to the barns and the women to the kitchen and the children to wait for the children's table.

From the yard you could see the flax. It was the forty acres on the bench above the river, and that morning it was blue all the way to the cottonwoods. It is not a blue you see anywhere else. It is the color of a thing that is going to be gone by afternoon. Every flower on that field opens at sunup and by the middle of the day lets go of its five petals, and the next morning there are new ones, and nobody has ever seen one flower last two days.

Vetter Paul did not come out to look at it. Vetter Paul was ninety-one and had been our preacher since before most of us were born, and since Easter he had lain in the small room at the end of the long house with the window toward the field, and his right hand did not work and his words came few. At Easter, when they carried him in to sit at the Lord's Supper for what everyone thought was the last time, he gave us one thing to keep

for the summer. He had been a boy in Russia and an old man in Dakota and he did not waste words.

Look at the flax, he said. *Before the blue is down, set it down.*

Set what down, nobody asked. We knew. In the spring of 1918 we had a great deal to set down.

> From the colony book, in the steward's hand, July 9: Taken by the men of the bond committee from town, to be sold for Liberty Bonds: steers, 64. Hogs, 30. Nothing paid. The men said we would get the sheep next.

We were Germans, they said in town, because we spoke German. We would not buy the bonds, because a bond is a gun with interest on it. We would not wear the uniform. In the spring they had taken our young men to the camps. Four boys from the Rockport colony down the river had been court-martialed in Washington State, and the word was that they were to go to the island prison in San Francisco Bay. Our own Samuel Kleinsasser was in the guardhouse at Camp Funston in Kansas for refusing to put on the shirt. His brother Andreas was nineteen and had not slept a night through since.

So that was the meditation of the summer. Before the blue is down. Every morning the field came up blue, and every morning a hundred and nineteen people went out under it carrying everything the town had done to us, and the hate came up with the sun as regular as the flax. And every afternoon the petals lay on the ground between the rows, and most days the hate was still standing.

II. Nine O'Clock

The flax bench · the same morning

We were weeding the flax by hand that week because the wild mustard had come up in it, and it was the young men and the girls in a line across the field, bent, pulling. When you weed flax in bloom

THE FLOWERS BRUSH YOUR FACE. IT IS LIKE WALKING THROUGH the sky in your work clothes.

Andreas was at the end of the line, next to the road. He pulled mustard as if every plant were a man on the bond committee. Basl Rebekka, who was the field boss for the girls and had a voice that could stop a runaway, watched him a while and then said, not loud, *Before the blue is down, Andreas.*

It is nine o'clock, he said. *I have till noon.*

Some laughed. It is a thing we do; we laugh at ourselves before anyone else can. But in the line, bent over, each of us knew what we were holding. For one it was the steers; she had raised a red one on a bottle and seen him go down the road on a rope. For one it was a word a storekeeper said to his wife at the counter. For one it was the boy in the guardhouse at Funston, whose one letter said he was well and was not allowed to say more, which was worse than anything it could have said. For one, and none of us said this aloud, it was the nice young woman in the bank who used to give the children peppermints and had stopped.

And for some of us it was not hate but its sister, the wanting. To have it back. To have it as it was before. To be let alone on our own ground with our own cattle. That holds as hard as hate does. Vetter Paul had said *set it down* and had not said which.

By ten the first petals were falling. You hear them if the wind is still: a very small sound, all over the field at once, like somebody a long way off turning the pages of a book.

III. Noon

The eating house · the same day

THEY CAME AT DINNER. THREE AUTOMOBILES AND A STOCK truck from town, and a dozen men we knew by name, because we had sold them geese and bought their binder twine for forty years. Mr. Lindahl from the elevator was one. He did not get out of the car.

They had come for the sheep, as they had said they would. Our steward, Vetter Michel, went out wiping his mouth and stood in front of them

and said what he had said the week before, that we could not stop them and would not try, and that what they did they would answer for and not we.

Somebody had painted the word on the side of the stock truck already, in yellow. One of the younger men threw a can of the same paint against the wall of the eating house, and it ran down the boards. Another of them, who was drunk at noon, which was the only thing about it that surprised us, spat on Vetter Michel's beard. Vetter Michel stood there with it on him.

That was when Andreas came round the corner of the wash house with a hay fork.

We tell this part plainly because it happened. He did not raise it. He came round the corner with it in his two hands and stopped, and everything in the yard stopped, the men from town and our men and the women in the doorway with the soup ladles, and the sheep in the pen. Andreas was a big boy and the fork was a three-tine fork with a fresh handle, and he stood holding it, and we could all see on his face that he wanted to, as much as he had ever wanted anything.

Basl Rebekka said from the eating-house door: *Andreas. It isn't noon yet.*

It was twelve minutes past. He knew it and she knew it. But he let the tines down onto the ground and leaned on the fork and stood there shaking while they loaded the sheep, a hundred and forty-one ewes and the two rams, and drove off with the paint still wet on the truck, and Mr. Lindahl in the back of the first car did not look at us.

> July 16: Taken for Liberty Bonds: sheep, 143. Nothing paid. A can of yellow paint left, three-quarters used.

Nobody ate the rest of dinner. Vetter Michel washed his beard at the pump. The women scraped the soup back into the kettle for supper, because we do not throw away food, not even then.

IV. Three O'Clock

The flax bench

We went back to the field because the mustard was still in it. By three the blue was mostly down. The petals lay in the furrows between the rows like a blue sheet somebody had torn and dropped, and the flax stood above them green with its little bare stars, already making seed.

Nobody spoke for a long time. Then the girls in the line began, very low, one of the old hymns, the long ones from the old country that take a quarter of an hour, and the young men took it up, and Andreas did not.

He said, to nobody: *It's easy for him. He's lying in bed. He doesn't have to stand in the yard.*

Nobody answered that. It was what we all thought. An old man in a bed can say set it down. He has already set down everything; his hands can't hold a spoon. We were young and strong and the town was taking us apart one animal at a time, and our brother was in the guardhouse at Funston, and the four Rockport boys were on their way to an island we had never seen. And it was coming on to evening, and the blue was down, and we were still holding it. Every one of us, the whole line. That was the first time in the summer that all of us knew it at once, standing in one row in one field.

We said to each other, then, out loud, which we had not done before: *Before the last of it falls. Not tomorrow. Today.* We went back to pulling mustard as if it mattered more than anything, and in a way, out there, it did.

V. Six O'Clock

The flax bench · toward evening

This is the part that is told more than one way, so we tell it the way most of us saw it.

The sun was low over the river and came across the field flat and yellow, and at the far end of the flax, where it runs out against the cottonwoods, Vetter Paul was standing.

He was in his black coat, with his hat, the way he went to the Lord's Supper. He was standing up straight, which he had not done since Easter. The light was behind him and also, some say, came from him; the girls at the near end of the line said the flax around his feet was blue again, a ring of it, as if it had opened for him late. He did not walk toward us. He stood, and he looked down the line at each of us, and then he raised his right hand, the one that did not work, and held it out flat and turned it over, the way you turn your hand over to let something drop out of it.

Then he said, and we all heard it at our different distances the same, as if he were standing beside each one: the story of Leonhard Keyser, that we had all had from him as children. How Keyser was a priest who came over to our people, and they took him to burn in Bavaria in 1527. How on the cart he leaned down and pulled a flower from the edge of the field, and held it up to the judge riding beside him. How they could not burn it.

He held it up, Vetter Paul said. *He didn't hold on to it.*

And then he gave us the words he had read to us at the long table every year of our lives.

> *... but in the morning, yea, also in the evening, all its beauty and all its glory are vanished. Thus it is also with all the comeliness of man; but few know themselves.*
>
> *— Matthias Servaes, letter, in the Martyrs Mirror*
>
> *... to requite hatred with love, evil with good, cursing with blessing; yea, must they, according to the doctrine of Christ, pray for them who oppress and persecute them.*
>
> *— Martyrs Mirror*

Then he turned his hand back over, empty, and was not there.

We are not people who see things. Our grandfathers came out of Russia without one vision among them, only the Book and the bell. We will tell you only what happened next. A hundred and nineteen of us, and the

line in the field was fewer than forty, but the women in the kitchen garden saw him too, and the old men mending harness at the barn door, and the children at the children's table through the window. Each of us had in our two hands what we had carried out that morning. The steers, the sheep, the paint, the word at the counter, the boy at Funston, the girl at the bank. The wanting it back. And each of us, wherever we stood, turned the hand over. Andreas Kleinsasser opened his and looked at it a long time and then laughed, short, as if somebody had told him a joke he had heard before, and sat down in the furrow on the petals and cried, and nobody went to him because nobody needed to.

It was not noon and it was not tomorrow. The last petals were still coming down.

His granddaughter Sanna, who sat with him afternoons, told us that at six o'clock he was asleep in his bed with the window open toward the field. She did not leave him for a minute. She said his right hand was lying on the cover turned palm up, which it could not do, and she had not turned it.

VI. Gebet

The evening service · and after

AT THE EVENING SERVICE VETTER MICHEL PRAYED FOR THE men from town, every one by name, Mr. Lindahl too, and that night for the first time that summer we could all say amen to it.

Vetter Paul died in September, before the move. By then the elders had been north and bought land across the line, and that fall and the next spring we went, nearly all of us, the way our people have always gone when a country could not keep us: Moravia, Hungary, Russia, Dakota, Canada. We sold the forty acres on the bench for what we could get. In November the two Hofer brothers from Rockport died at Leavenworth, and one of them came home in the uniform he had refused to put on, and we sang for them on the way north. Samuel Kleinsasser came out of Funston thin as a lath in the spring of 1919 and found his brother waiting for him at the depot in Manitoba with a team.

We are not saying we never hated again. We are people. But we knew after that what it was to set it down all at once, a whole field of us, and that it can be done in a day, and that it does not take a lifetime unless you let it.

The new owner of the bench did not sow flax. He put it in wheat. But flax volunteers; the seed lies in the ground a long time. For years, people on the river road said, a few plants came up every summer along the edge by the cottonwoods, in a ring, and opened blue at sunup, and let go before noon.

Background

The verse

> *As the Vassika plant sheds its withered flowers, men should shed passion and hatred, O ye Bhikshus!*
>
> Dhammapada 377, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, five hundred monks take a meditation subject from the Buddha and go to practice in the forest. They see jasmine flowers that opened that morning dropping from their stems by evening, and resolve to be released from lust, hatred and delusion before the flowers are released from theirs. The Buddha, sitting in his Perfumed Chamber at Jetavana, sends forth a radiant image of himself to them and speaks the verse, and all five hundred reach awakening. Read the full commentary story.

James River, South Dakota

The Hutterites in 1918

The Hutterites are communal Anabaptists who trace their origin to Moravia in the 1520s and came to Dakota Territory from Russia between 1874 and 1877. They hold all property in common, eat together, attend a service every evening, and practice *Gelassenheit*, yieldedness or self-surrender. As German-speaking pacifists they were singled out during the First World War. In the summer and fall of 1918 colonies in the Dakotas and Montana had sheep and cattle seized and auctioned to buy Liberty Bonds, and drafted young men who refused uniforms were held in army camps and prisons. Four men from the Rockport colony, David, Joseph and Michael Hofer and Jacob Wipf, were court-martialed and held at Alcatraz, then moved to Fort Leavenworth, where Joseph died on November 29 and Michael on December 2, 1918; Joseph's body was sent home dressed in the uniform he had refused. Nearly all the colonies moved to Canada in 1918 and the years after (Encyclopedia of the Great Plains). The colony in this story, its people and its flax field are invented.

The *Martyrs Mirror* (1660), Thieleman van Braght's collection of accounts and letters of Anabaptist martyrs, is quoted here in Joseph F. Sohm's English translation of 1886 (full text); it includes the burning of Leonhard Keyser at Schärding in 1527 and the letters of Matthias Servaes. Each flower of flax lasts only a day and is replaced by new ones each morning (National Park Service).

After the story of the five hundred monks from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 377). The original. Scripture from the *Martyrs Mirror*, translated by Joseph F. Sohm (1886). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

25.9

Sifted Meal

Silent am I now and still,
Dare not in thy presence move.
— Charles Wesley, "Open, Lord, my inward ear"

This is the way it was told, at the north end of Salt Spring Island.

I. The Winter

Above Vesuvius Bay, Salt Spring Island · January 1862

Keziah Tolliver was sifting the last of the meal when the panther came into the house.

It was the winter the cold killed the stock. Ice stood in the passage between the island and Vancouver's Island, the boat from Victoria had not called at Vesuvius Bay in three weeks, and her husband was on the other side of that ice with the money for flour. She had a boy of six named Eli and a baby girl. The cow had died standing. They had a calf left in the lean-to, and in the dusk she heard the calf scream once, and then heard nothing at all.

The door was a split-cedar door on leather hinges. It came in slowly, the way a door does when a dog noses it, and the thing that put its head around the edge was the color of a dead fern and as long as she was.

She let the sieve go. It rang on the puncheons, and the meal went out across the floor in a pale skim. She sat down in it where she stood, with the baby in her lap and her back against the hearth stones, and she pulled the boy down against her side.

Eli. Don't you move a finger. Don't move a foot. We are not people who run.

The panther walked the room. It ate the venison off the table. It came across the floor and stood over them long enough that she could count its

breaths, and she did count them, to have something to do that was not moving. Then it lay down between them and the door with its tail around its feet, the way a cat lies down in a house where it lives.

The fire burned to coals and went grey. The baby slept, which Keziah afterward called the one mercy she had asked for by name. The boy did not sleep. She could feel him against her ribs, awake, held as still as a rabbit in grass, and some time in the night she felt the holding go out of him and something else come in, which was only stillness, with nothing behind it pushing.

When there was light enough to see the window, the panther stood, stretched itself fore and aft, looked once around the four walls, and went out the way it had come.

Mr. Pryor, who taught the school, came by an hour later on his way down to Central and found the door standing open. He looked at the floor before he looked at her. The cat's prints were in the meal, round and deep, four toes and no claws. They went to within a hand of her skirt, went around her, and went back. There was no other mark in it anywhere. The meal lay drifted against her hem and against the boy's bare heel just as it had fallen, like snow against a stump.

Mrs. Tolliver, he said. *You may get up now.*

She found that she could not, right away, and he waited.

II. What They Said

The north end · 1862 *to* 1873

After that winter the island said that Keziah Tolliver was a panther.

They did not say it unkindly. A panther had walked up to a woman with a baby in her lap, they said, and seen its own cousin, and lain down. Old Kimo at the south end, a Kanaka who had packed for the Company for thirty years and fished now off Isabella Point, said he had known it the first time he saw her walk. And everybody on the island knew how it was with the she-panthers of the Divide, or said so.

When one of them has made her kill, they said, she goes up into a cave under the high rocks, and the floor of that cave is laid a hand deep with the red dust of rotted cedar and the yellow dust of old maple leaves. She lies down on it and she lies seven days. On the seventh day she gets up and looks at her bed. If a twitch of her tail or her ear has scattered that dust, or a forefoot or a hind foot has, she tells herself, *That does not suit what you were born,* and she lies down again and goes hungry seven days more. If the dust is as she left it, she tells herself, *That suits what you were born.* She comes out of the cave, yawns, stretches, looks to the north and the east and the south and the west, screams three times, and goes hunting.

It was out of a mother like that, people said, that Eli Tolliver had come.

Some of what they said was true. Keziah had been born in Clay County, Missouri, the property of a man who raised hemp. When she was nine her mother was sold off the courthouse steps at Liberty. Her mother had stood up there with her hands at her sides and her eyes on the top of a sycamore across the square, and had not moved a hand or a foot or her face while they bid, and had said one thing to Keziah the night before. *Don't give them anything. Don't give them one finger of you.* Keziah had walked to California at nineteen beside another man's wagon. She was free there, and stayed seven years, until the laws turned. In 1858 she came north on the steamer from San Francisco with a husband and a boy of two, one of some hundreds who went that year, because a governor at Victoria had sent word that they might own land and vote.

So on winter evenings she took the sieve and shook a skim of meal over the bench by the hearth, and Eli sat on it while his father read the chapter. When the chapter was done she looked. If the meal was scattered she said, *That is not what you come from,* and he sat again the next night with no bread first. If it lay as she had sifted it, she said, *That is what you come from,* and brushed it back into the bowl. By the time he was nine she had stopped looking, and at ten he was sifting the meal for his sisters.

III. The Bench

The log schoolhouse at Central · spring 1873

AT SEVENTEEN ELI TOLLIVER WAS A LONG, SPARE YOUNG MAN who cleared land with his father and kept forty sheep. Nobody on the island had seen him do a needless thing with his hands. He did not drum on a table or pick at a cuff. On the school bench he sat with his palms on his knees and his feet side by side through a two-hour sermon, whenever a preacher rowed over from Nanaimo, and through the meetings afterward, where the men talked about roads and wharves and who would sit on the new council. He did not yawn. He did not put his legs out in front of him. He spoke when he was asked something, said the amount that answered it, and stopped.

They were not easy years to sit still in. Three men of the settlement had been killed in their own cabins in '67 and '68, one of them the man who taught the Sunday school in that same room, and not everyone on the north end believed the right man had hanged for it. Families had sold out and gone to Victoria. The boys Eli's age had gone to the Nanaimo pits for wages. In the schoolhouse of an evening, when a limb came down outside, every head went around except one.

That spring a panther began taking sheep along the lake. The men made up a purse of twenty dollars, and since it was agreed that only one person on the island could outwait a cat, they brought the purse to Eli and offered him a dead ewe to sit over.

I won't sit over a bait, he said. He said it pleasantly and gave no reason. He took his blanket down to the fold instead and sat there nights with no gun, and no sheep was taken from any fold he sat by, and he would not take the twenty dollars for that either. People said the cat knew a relation.

On a Sunday in May, after meeting, some of the young people stayed behind where Mr. Pryor was stacking the slates. He had kept school on the island fourteen years, the first ten of them for no pay but what families carried to his door, and he was not a man who talked for pleasure.

Sir, we never saw anybody like Eli Tolliver. When he sits down he doesn't move his hands. He doesn't move his feet. He doesn't yawn or stretch himself out. Not ever.

Eli was at the door with his hat in his hand, waiting on his sisters, and heard it. He did not turn around.

Mr. Pryor set the slates down.

Anyone who means to follow his Lord ought to be like Eli Tolliver. Quiet in what he does, and in what he says, and in what he thinks.

He had a way of lining out a hymn, two lines at a time, for a room where not everyone could read. He lined one out then, to nobody in particular, with the slates at his elbow.

> *From the world of sin, and noise,*
> *And hurry, I withdraw;*
> *For the small and inward voice*
> *I wait with humble awe;*
> *Silent am I now and still,*
> *Dare not in thy presence move;*
> *To my waiting soul reveal*
> *The secret of thy love.*
>
> *— Charles Wesley, "Open, Lord, my inward ear" (1742)*

He turned down twenty dollars last month, Mr. Pryor said. *You might think about that, too.* And he went back to the slates.

IV. The Door

The Tolliver place · that evening

Eli walked home behind his sisters without saying anything, which was usual.

He had sat still eleven years because of where he came from. He had known that the way he knew his name. But standing in the schoolhouse door with his back to the room, hearing the hymn come two lines at a time, he had looked for the thing in him that did the keeping still, the

hand on the scruff, and it was gone. He could not have said when it went. The stillness was there with nobody holding it. It was like the meal on the floor that morning when he was six, lying as it fell.

His mother had supper on. She was past forty and still walked like something that had come down off the Divide. She looked at him once across the table and then looked again, longer, the way Mr. Pryor had once looked at her floor.

Afterward he went and stood in the doorway. The light was going. He yawned, which his sisters had never seen and talked about for a week. He put both arms over his head and stretched until his knuckles touched the lintel. He looked north toward the bay, and east over the lake, and south to the Divide, and west where the sun was going down behind Vancouver's Island.

Then he called the sheep, three times, the long call, and went down to the fold.

Keziah got up and went to the bench by the hearth. The little girls had sifted it for their brother that evening as a joke, since he was too old for it, and he had sat there through the chapter anyway. The meal lay on the board as fine and even as frost. She stood looking at it with the bowl in her hand, and then she set the bowl down and left it for the morning.

Background

The verse

> *The Bhikshu whose body and tongue and mind are quieted, who is collected, and has rejected the baits of the world, he is called quiet.*
>
> Dhammapada 378, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Santakāya ("Calm in Body") never makes an improper movement of hand or foot, never yawns and never stretches. It was said that he had been born of a lioness, and that a lioness who has found prey lies seven days in a cave on a bed of red and yellow mineral powder. If she finds on the seventh day that a movement of her tail, ears or feet has scattered the powder, she tells herself, "This does not become your birth or lineage," and lies fasting seven days more. If the powder is undisturbed she comes out, yawns, stretches, surveys the four quarters,

roars three times and goes hunting. The monks report the elder's composure to the Buddha, who says a monk should be like him, composed in action, speech and thought, and at the end of the verse the elder becomes an arahant. Read the full commentary story.

Salt Spring Island, British Columbia

Salt Spring Island, 1858–1873

In 1858, after California passed a series of laws against its Black residents, several hundred of them accepted an invitation from Governor James Douglas and sailed from San Francisco to Victoria. Beginning in 1859 a number of these families took up land on the north end of Salt Spring Island, the first place in the colony where settlers could pre-empt unsurveyed land. Many had been born enslaved; the best known of them, Sylvia Stark, was born in Clay County, Missouri, crossed the plains to California as a girl, and lived on the island until 1944. The Tollivers and Mr. Pryor are invented, but the island's first teacher was a Black graduate of Oberlin College, John Craven Jones, who taught for years without pay in a log schoolhouse at Central, built in 1861, that also served as the church. The BC Black History Awareness Society and the Salt Spring Island Archives have mapped the homesteads.

The winter of 1861–62 was cold enough to kill livestock across the island. Settlers' accounts are full of cougars, which they called panthers; the archives note that the teacher held school in two places so that children would not have to walk far through cougar country. Between 1867 and 1868 three Black settlers were killed near Vesuvius Bay, among them the Sunday school teacher William Robinson. An Indigenous man, Tshuanahusset, was hanged for Robinson's death on evidence that historians now doubt, and a number of families left the island afterward. Hawaiians who had worked for the Hudson's Bay Company, known as Kanakas, settled around the island's south end in the same decades. Charles Wesley's hymn was first published in 1742 and stood in Methodist hymnbooks throughout the nineteenth century.

After the story of the Elder Santakāya from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 378). The original. Hymn by Charles Wesley (1742), from John Wesley's *Collection of Hymns for the Use of the People Called Methodists*. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

25.10

The Scythe

> *But let the clothes of which he was divested be put aside in the wardrobe and kept there.*
> *— Rule of St. Benedict, ch. 58*

Így hallottam, on the hill above Mount Angel.

I. The Road

Marion County, Oregon · August 1963

Ferenc Gál owned a scythe, a pair of work trousers gone white at the knees, one shirt, and a cardboard suitcase with a Red Cross label on it from a camp in New Jersey. He was thirty-three years old. He had been in America six years and nine months, and in that time he had picked strawberries and pole beans and filberts and Christmas trees, he had strung hop yards in the spring and fed vines into the picking machines in August, he had grubbed stumps and pulled mustard out of wheat and plowed for German farmers who did not want to plow on Saturday, and he had mowed ditch banks, which was what he was best at, and what he was doing on the afternoon Brother Meinrad saw him.

The scythe was his own. He had bought the blade in Salem, from a hardware store that still carried them for the old Swiss, and made the snath himself out of ash, the way his grandfather had made them on the Great Plain east of the Tisza, with the two handles set to the length of his own arm. Everything else he had was borrowed or given or worn through. The shirt had been a good flannel shirt when a church in Portland gave it to him in 1957. Now it was more hole than shirt, and the holes had been mended with thread of other colors, and the mending had holes.

He was walking the road at the foot of the butte with the scythe on his shoulder, going back to the hop grower's bunkhouse at the end of the day, when the abbey's truck came down the hill and passed him and stopped.

Brother Meinrad was seventy-four. He had come from a farm in the canton of Obwalden in 1911, at nineteen, because the monks at Engelberg had told him there was land in Oregon and they needed somebody who knew cows, and he had milked the abbey's cows and cut the abbey's hay for fifty-two years. He leaned across the cab and looked at the scythe a long time before he looked at the man.

You made that snath, he said. His English still had the mountains in it.

Yes.

Where are you from?

Ferenc told him. Not all of it. He did not tell people all of it. He said: a village on the Plain, and then the collective, and then Budapest, the island at Csepel, the steel works, a laborer, eight years. He said: 1956. He did not have to say any more than that. Everybody in America in 1963 knew what 1956 meant if you said it in that accent. He did not say what he had done in the steel works in the first eleven days of November, or what he had seen at the end of them, or how he had walked to Austria in the dark across the marsh to the little bridge at Andau with his scythe blade wrapped in a coat because it was the only thing of his grandfather's he had.

Brother Meinrad looked at the shirt.

If this is how you live, he said, *why don't you come up the hill?*

Ferenc laughed. It was not a laugh he was proud of.

Up the hill. Who would take a man like me up the hill? I have no Latin. I have no money. I have a green card and a scythe.

I would take you, said Brother Meinrad. *If you'll come.*

Ferenc stood in the road. A pickup full of hop sacks went by and blew dust over both of them. He thought about the bunkhouse, where nine men slept on iron cots and one of them coughed all night. He thought about September, when the hop harvest would be over and the grower

would pay them off and there would be nothing until the filberts. He thought about the winter before, and the one before that.

All right, he said. *If you will take me, I'll come.*

II. The Oak

Mount Angel Abbey · August and September

The abbey stood on top of the butte, four hundred feet above the town and the fields, the way abbeys stand on top of things in Switzerland, which was why the Swiss had put it there. The Indians had called the hill something else before the Swiss came. Brother Meinrad said the old people in town said it was a place where the tribes had come to pray, from as far as the Klamath country, and that the monks had not chosen it by accident, whatever they told you. There was a church with two towers, and the long brick monastery that had been built after the fire of 1926, and the seminary, and gardens, and a grove of fir, and, out at the edge where the drive came up from the road and the abbey's ground ended, a white oak older than any of it, low and wide, with its lower limbs out flat over the grass like arms.

Brother Meinrad took him to the dairy barn first. He ran water into the steel sink where they washed the milk cans, hot, and had him take off the shirt and bend over, and he washed Ferenc's head with a bar of soap and his own old hands, and cut his hair short with the clippers he used on the calves when they had ringworm, and washed it again. Ferenc stood bent over the sink in the barn with his eyes shut and the hot water going down the back of his neck. Nobody had touched his head since his mother. He did not say anything. He could not have.

Then Brother Meinrad gave him a set of work clothes out of a closet, clean, patched, smelling of naphtha, and stood holding the old shirt and trousers by two fingers.

The Rule says we keep a man's old clothes in the wardrobe, he said. *So that if he ever goes back to the world, he goes back the way he came. That's in the Rule. Chapter fifty-eight.* He looked at the shirt. *The wardrobe is full. Come.*

They walked out the drive to the white oak at the edge of the grounds, where you could see the whole valley spread out below, the town and the spire of its church and the hop yards and the wheat stubble and the filbert orchards in their rows, all the way to the Cascades, and Mount Hood standing up white at the end of it. Brother Meinrad hung the shirt on one of the low limbs, and the trousers over it. Then he looked at Ferenc, and Ferenc understood, and reached up and hung the scythe in the crotch of the limb by its snath, with the blade turned in toward the trunk so nobody walking under it would be cut.

There, said Brother Meinrad. *Now they're kept.*

• • •

He was a postulant first, and in the spring he would be a novice, and they gave him a black habit for the choir and a work habit for the barn and a name, because in those years the Benedictines still gave you a new name, and the name was Brother Isidore. Isidore the farmer, Brother Meinrad told him. A hired man in Spain who plowed another man's fields, and the angels came and plowed beside him while he prayed. Some of the young monks from the seminary, who had been to college, called him Brother Plowman, and he let them.

The novice master was Father Placid. He was eighty-one. He had come from Engelberg as a boy with Brother Meinrad's older brother, and he had been a professor of Greek in the college before the war and had gone almost blind since, and now he sat in a chair by the window of the novitiate with his hands folded on the Rule and taught the novices what was in it, which he had by heart. He spoke so seldom and so quietly that the novices leaned forward when he did. He had a long face and white eyebrows and he did not, as far as Brother Isidore could tell in the first month, ever look at anybody, though everyone agreed he saw everything.

At the end of two months, the way the Rule said, Father Placid read Chapter 58 to him, the whole of it, sitting in his chair by the window, and at the end of it he said the thing the Rule says to say, in his quiet voice, looking out the window at nothing.

Here is the law under which you wish to fight. If you can observe it, enter; if you cannot, you are free to depart.

Brother Isidore had been free to depart from a great many places in his life, most of them at night. He said he would stay.

III. Bread

Autumn and winter, 1963

They rose at four-thirty for Vigils. They sang the Office seven times a day in Latin, the whole Psalter in a week, all hundred and fifty, the way the Rule said, and Brother Isidore stood in the back row of the choir with the lay brothers and did not know the Latin and learned it by sound, the way he had learned English by sound in the hop yards. He worked in the dairy with Brother Meinrad and in the orchard and in the woodlot. He ate in the refectory in silence while a monk read aloud from a pulpit, and the food was good. The food was very good.

That was the thing he had not expected. The farmers in the valley gave the abbey everything. They brought eggs in flats and cream in cans and sides of beef at butchering, and in November, when they killed hogs, they brought sausages and smoked hams and blood pudding in such quantities that the cellarer stood in the kitchen door with his hands up. The women of Mount Angel brought kuchen and stollen and cookies in tins, and the hop growers brought money, and at Christmas a man who had made a fortune in prunes brought a crate of oranges from California for every monk in the house. They gave it because their grandparents had given it, and because they wanted the monks to pray for them, and because the abbey on the hill was the best thing they had and they wanted it to have the best of what they had. And Brother Isidore, who had stood in line before dawn at the labor contractors' trucks in Salem with a lunch of bread and an onion in a paper sack, ate their hams and their stollen and their oranges, and he put on weight, and his face filled out, and the cough he had brought from the bunkhouse went away.

Somewhere in November he began to be ashamed of it.

It came on him first at table, with the reader in the pulpit reading something he did not follow and a plate of ham and potatoes in front of him that a farmer's wife had cured in her own smokehouse. He thought: who earned this? Not me. In Csepel, on the wall of the rolling mill, there had been a sign in letters a meter high, the old saying the Party had borrowed from Saint Paul, that he who does not work shall not eat. He had hated that sign for eight years. He found that he believed it. He thought: I am a grown man and I am eating another man's ham. Another man's oranges. I sing in a language I do not understand and they feed me for it. In the hop yards I was paid by the hour and it was mine. In Salem the cannery pays more. A man could have a room. A man could have a car, in two years, and go where he liked, and nobody would ring a bell to tell him when to get up and when to eat and when to stop talking.

He thought: I walked across a marsh at night to be free, and I have come to the top of a hill to obey an old man who can't see.

On the twenty-second of November, a Friday, the bells of the abbey rang at the wrong hour, slowly, and kept ringing, and the monks came out of the barns and the classrooms and stood on the lawn not knowing why until the prior came out of the house and told them that the President had been shot in Texas and was dead. The town bells answered from the valley below. That night the abbot said a Requiem, and the monks sang the Dies Irae, and Brother Isidore stood in the back row of the choir and thought about the morning of the fourth of November, seven years before, when the tanks came into Budapest at three in the morning and at twenty past five Imre Nagy's voice came over the radio to say that the Soviet troops were attacking, and he could not stop shaking, and could not have said whether it was the grief for a man he had never met or something that had been waiting in him for seven years to come out.

The next evening, after Vespers, when the others went in to supper, he went out the drive in the dark to the white oak.

IV. Szégyentelen

The white oak · November 1963 to March 1964

It was raining, the long fine Willamette rain that does not fall so much as stand in the air. The shirt was still on its limb. It had been out three months and it was black with wet and green along the seams with something growing, and the trousers under it hung straight down heavy with water, and above them in the crotch of the limb the blade of the scythe showed a line of orange rust along its back where the rain had run.

He took the shirt down and held it. It smelled of oak and rain and under that, still, of the bunkhouse and the hop kilns and himself.

He had meant to put it on. He had meant to put it on and take down the scythe and walk down the hill in the dark and be in Salem by morning and stand in line at the cannery. Instead he stood under the oak holding it, and he heard himself talking out loud, in Hungarian, the way he had talked to himself in the bunkhouses and the berry fields and on the marsh at Andau, because there was nobody else in America to talk to in it.

Szégyentelen, he said. *You shameless one. Look at you. Look at what you want. You want to put this back on. This. You want to go back down there and stand in the dark at five in the morning in front of the contractor's truck with your hat in your hand, so a man with a cigar can look at your arms and decide whether you're worth a day's wage. You want to sleep in a room with nine men and a cough. You want to sell your back by the hour like a horse. That's freedom? You walked to Austria for that? Shameless. They washed your head. An old man washed your head with his own hands in a barn. They fed you. They gave you a name. And you want to put on your rags and go hire yourself out. Go on, then. Put it on. Shameless.*

Then, because it was what was in his mouth, he said the psalm they had sung that week at Compline, the one he had learned the sound of before he learned the meaning, and had then gone and looked up in the English Bible in the novitiate library, because he had wanted to know what it was that the soul was being asked.

> *Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why dost thou disquiet me? Hope thou in God, for I will still give praise to him: the salvation of my countenance, and my God.*
>
> *— Psalm 41:12 (Douay-Rheims)*

He said it until he was done saying it. Then he stood in the rain with the shirt in his hands, and the thing in him that had been pulling at him for a month like a dog on a rope stopped pulling, and lay down. He hung the shirt back on its limb. He walked back up the drive to the house, and went in to Compline late, and knelt at the back, and slept that night all the way through to the bell.

It lasted until the second week of Advent. Then it was the hams again, and the bell, and the Latin, and a letter from his sister in Kecskemét that said their mother was not well and that the parcel he had sent had arrived opened and half empty, and he went down the drive after Vespers to the oak and took down the shirt and said all of it again, out loud, to himself, in Hungarian, in the dark. *Szégyentelen.* And it lay down again, and he came back.

In January he went four times. In February, twice. In March, once, on a night of wind, when the limbs of the oak were knocking together over his head and the scythe blade rang very faintly in the crotch of the limb every time the wind moved it, a thin high note like a struck glass.

• • •

The other novices noticed. There were six of them, five young Americans out of the seminary and one German boy from the town, and in a house where everybody is always where they are supposed to be, a man who is not where he is supposed to be after Vespers is noticed. One evening in February the German boy, whose name in religion was Brother Benno and who had grown up on a farm below the hill and knew every tree on it, met him coming back up the drive with his hood up and rain on his face.

Where do you go, Brother Isidore? Every week. Out to the road.

To see my teacher, said Brother Isidore.

Brother Benno thought about that. There was nothing out at the road but the oak and the abbey's cemetery a little way down the slope, where the dead monks lay in their rows under the iron crosses, back to 1882. Brother Benno told the others, and the others decided among themselves that Brother Isidore had some old monk in the cemetery he went to pray to, some Swiss lay brother from the early days, and they thought better of him for it, and asked no more.

V. The Hayfield

Spring 1964

After March he did not go anymore.

He did not decide not to. It was only that the thing that had sent him went quiet one night in the wind under the oak and did not get up again. The hams were hams. The bell was the bell. When it rang he got up, and when he got up he was glad to be up, and when he sang he sang, and when he ate he ate, and when he milked he milked, and there did not seem to be anybody left over standing off to one side watching him do it and adding up whether it was worth it. He could not have explained it any better than that, and nobody asked him to.

In June, when the grass on the hilltop meadows was up to a man's waist, Brother Meinrad's tractor broke a pitman arm on the mower and there was a week's wait for the part from Portland, and the hay could not wait a week. Brother Meinrad stood at the edge of the meadow behind the church and looked at it, and then looked at Brother Isidore.

Brother Isidore walked out the drive to the oak. He did not take down the shirt. He did not look at it. He reached up and took the scythe out of the crotch of the limb, and walked back with it, and sat on an upturned bucket in the dairy barn for an hour with a whetstone and a hammer and an anvil the size of his fist, drawing the edge out again the way his grandfather had taught him on the Plain, tap and tap and tap, until the rust was gone and the edge was thin as paper. Then he went out into the meadow behind the church and mowed it. He mowed it for three days, in his work habit with the skirts tucked up into his belt, the long even swaths going

down behind him and lying in rows in the sun, and the novices came out after their own work to rake, and the old monks came and stood at the edge of the meadow with their hands in their sleeves to watch, because there were men in that house who had not seen a man mow with a scythe since they were boys in Switzerland and had not thought to see it again.

When it was done he cleaned the blade and oiled it and carried the scythe back out to the oak and hung it up again in the crotch of the limb, blade in, where it had been. He did not think anything about doing it. It was where the scythe was kept.

Brother Benno was raking the last row at the far end of the meadow, and saw him come back.

Brother Isidore, he said, at recreation that evening, with the others listening. *You haven't been out to see your teacher since Lent. Not once. We've been watching. You went out today, but you didn't stay.*

No.

Did he die on you, your teacher? said one of the Americans, and the others laughed, not unkindly.

Brother Isidore was mending a halter across his knees. He went on mending it.

When I was in the world, he said, *I went back and forth. To the oak and back. To the oak and back. Now I am not in the world anymore. So I don't go back and forth.*

The room was quiet. It was not the kind of thing a novice said. The Americans looked at each other. One of them had a copy of the Rule in the pocket of his habit, as they all did, and he took it out and found the place, because they had been taught to settle things that way, and read it out, Chapter 4, the sixty-first tool of good works: *Not to wish to be called holy before one is holy; but first to be holy, that one may be truly so called.*

The next morning two of them went to Father Placid.

VI. The Tools

The novitiate · June 1964

Father Placid was in his chair by the window with the Rule on his knees, closed. He did not need it open. He listened to the two novices without turning his head. They said that Brother Isidore had been going out to the oak by the road all winter, every week, sometimes twice, in the dark, and that he had told them he was going to see his teacher, and that now he said he did not need to go anymore because he was not in the world anymore. They said that he was a novice of nine months. They said that it was either a lie or pride, and that either way somebody should say something.

When they were done Father Placid sat a while longer. Out the window, past the cloister garden, you could see the end of the drive and the white oak, and in the crotch of its lowest limb, if you knew where to look, a short dark curve that was the back of a scythe blade.

He told you the truth, said Father Placid.

The two novices waited.

He had a teacher, said the old man. *It is hanging on that tree. A shirt and a scythe. When he wanted to go back to the world, he went to his teacher, and his teacher showed him what the world was for him, and he scolded himself, and came home. Nobody else scolded him. Nobody else needed to. He has sat in that chair every week since November and told me all of it himself, the way the Rule says a monk should tell his evil thoughts to his spiritual father.* He turned his head then, for the first time, and the two novices saw his eyes, which were clouded white and looked at them anyway. *He kept guard over himself. Now he doesn't need the guard. That's all. A man who has stopped going back and forth has not left the enclosure, Brother. He has arrived in it.*

Then he said the tools over to them, from the Fourth Chapter, out of his memory, the way he had said them to every novice who had come through that room for twenty years.

> *To keep constant guard over the actions of one's life. To know for certain that God sees one everywhere. When evil thoughts come into one's heart, to dash them against Christ immediately.*
>
> *Now the workshop in which we shall diligently execute all these tasks is the enclosure of the monastery and stability in the community.*
>
> *— Rule of St. Benedict, ch. 4*

He told me he used to sell his back by the hour like a horse, said Father Placid. *Saint James knew about horses.* And he said that too.

> *For in many things we all offend. If any man offend not in word, the same is a perfect man. He is able also with a bridle to lead about the whole body. For if we put bits into the mouths of horses, that they may obey us: and we turn about their whole body.*
>
> *— James 3:2–3 (Douay-Rheims)*

Some of us need the whole bridle all our lives, said Father Placid. *I have needed it. Brother Isidore put the bit in his own mouth, and turned himself around with it, and now he has taken it out again because he doesn't need it. Go and learn from him. Go on.*

They went, and did not say anything to Brother Isidore, then or later.

• • •

The shirt went the way shirts go. By the next winter it was rags on the limb, and by the one after that it was a few threads, and then one spring it was not there, and nobody saw it go. The trousers lasted a year longer. The scythe stayed.

Brother Isidore took it down every June for thirty years and mowed the meadow behind the church, long after the abbey had new mowers and did not need him to, because the old monks liked to watch and then because the young monks did, and every June when it was done he oiled it and hung it back in the crotch of the oak, blade in. When his shoulders would no longer swing it he stopped taking it down. He died in the infirmary in the winter of 2009, seventy-nine years old, and they buried him

in the cemetery down the slope, in the row with Brother Meinrad and Father Placid, under an iron cross that said BR. ISIDORE GÁL, O.S.B.

The oak is still there at the end of the drive, though the snath rotted out of it long ago. The tree took the blade. Year by year the wood came up around it the way a white oak will around anything you leave in it, a fence wire, a horseshoe, a nail, until there was nothing left showing but the very tip of the back of it, a thin curve of dark iron set into the grey bark of the crotch, which the novices are still shown when they come, on their first walk out the drive, and which in a low evening light, from the right place on the road, looks exactly like the new moon.

Background

The verses

> *Rouse thyself by thyself, examine thyself by thyself, thus self-protected and attentive wilt thou live happily, O Bhikshu!*
>
> Dhammapada 379, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *For self is the lord of self, self is the refuge of self; therefore curb thyself as the merchant curbs a good horse.*
>
> Dhammapada 380, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk meets a poor hired laborer walking along in a ragged loincloth with a plow on his shoulder and asks why he does not go forth. The man asks who would ordain someone like him; the monk says he will, takes him to Jetavana, bathes him with his own hands, ordains him, and has him hang his loincloth and plow on the branch of a tree at the edge of the monastery grounds. He is named Naṅgalakula, "Plowman." Living on the rich offerings given to the Buddha, he grows discontented and decides to go back to work for hire. But at the tree he scolds himself ("Shameless fellow!") and returns, and he does this again each time the discontent comes back. When the monks ask where he keeps going, he says he is visiting his teacher. Soon he reaches arahantship and stops going, and when the monks tease him, he says that while he was bound to the world he went back and forth, and now he does not. They report this to the Buddha as a false claim; the Buddha says it is true, since his son has admonished himself and reached the goal. Read the full commentary story. A close twin of the story, about the monk Pilotika, is told in 10.10, The Sugar Sack.

Mount Angel, Oregon

Mount Angel and the Hungarians, 1956-1964

Mount Angel Abbey was founded in 1882 by Benedictine monks from the Abbey of Engelberg in Switzerland. It stands on a butte about 485 feet high above the farm town of Mount Angel in the Willamette Valley, a hill that, as the Oregon Encyclopedia notes, Native people had long used as a place of prayer. Bavarian Catholic settlers followed the monks, and the monastery was rebuilt after a fire destroyed it in 1926. The surrounding country grew hops, berries, filberts and grain; by the early 1950s machines had replaced the big hop-picking crews. The Rule of St. Benedict requires that a newly received monk's own clothes be kept in the wardrobe, so that if he ever leaves he can be sent out in them; the passages here are from Leonard Doyle's 1948 translation.

In the Hungarian Revolution of 1956, the Soviet army returned to Budapest early on November 4, and the workers' district of Csepel was one of the last places to hold out, until November 11. About 200,000 Hungarians fled the country. Some 70,000 crossed into Austria over the small bridge at Andau, which James Michener made famous in *The Bridge at Andau*. Most of those admitted to the United States passed through Camp Kilmer in New Jersey between November 1956 and June 1957 before being resettled around the country.

After the story of the Elder Naṅgalakula from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 379 and 380). The original. Scripture from the Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision) and the Rule of St. Benedict, tr. Leonard J. Doyle (1948). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

25.11

Heart Mountain

> *Since they have meditated on Buddha's body, they will also see Buddha's mind. It is great compassion that is called Buddha's mind.*
> — *Amitâyur-dhyâna-sûtra § 18*

***Nyoze gamon*, in Block 22.**

I. The Bucket

Pomona Assembly Center, Los Angeles County Fairgrounds · May 1942

Shigeru Nakai was nineteen, and until the second week of May he had been a sophomore at U.C.L.A. with a slide rule in a leather case and a plan to be an engineer. His father, a doctor on East First Street, had been taken by the F.B.I. on the night of December 7 with his medical bag still in his hand, and was in a camp in Montana, and wrote once a month on paper with holes cut in it. Shig had brought his mother and his little sister to the fairgrounds at Pomona on the bus, with the two suitcases each that they were allowed, and had stood in the line for typhoid shots and in the line for mattress ticking to stuff with straw, and on the third evening, sitting on the step of Barrack 14 in the heat with the asphalt still soft from the day, he saw the gardener.

He was a man of about fifty, in a clean khaki shirt with the sleeves rolled, carrying a bucket of water down the row between the barracks. Somebody had planted a little pepper tree at the end of the row, a seedling a foot high in a coffee can, and the man knelt and gave it water a cupful at a time, watching it go into the dirt, and then stood up and went back for more. That was all he did. Shig watched him make the trip four times.

He could not afterward explain what it was. The man was not handsome, exactly, though he had a fine straight back and a face that looked as if it had been out in the weather a long time and come to terms with it. It was the way he carried the bucket. It was the way he knelt. Everything else in the fairgrounds that week was waiting in a line, or shouting about a lost suitcase, or crying behind a sheet hung across a barrack room, and this man was watering a pepper tree as though nobody had told him there was anything wrong.

That's Mr. Hamada, a woman on the next step said. *He was a gardener in Sawtelle. He taught the Sunday school at the temple out there, and when they took the sensei he did the services himself. He's very good.*

Shig went to the young people's study group in the mess hall that Sunday because Mr. Hamada would be there. He went the next Sunday, and the Wednesday evening, and then he went everywhere Mr. Hamada was. He did not much care what was said at the meetings. He sat where he could see the man's face, and looked at it, and was content in a way he had not been since December.

His mother noticed and said nothing. His mother had a good deal else to notice that summer.

II. The Stone Garden

Heart Mountain, Wyoming · autumn 1942 to spring 1943

The trains brought them to Wyoming in August, three days and nights with the blinds pulled down, and let them off on a sagebrush flat between Cody and Powell where hundreds of tar-paper barracks stood in rows inside a barbed-wire fence. West of the camp, eight miles off across the flat, the mountain stood up by itself out of the plain, grey limestone with a steep blunt head on it, and whichever way you turned in Heart Mountain you saw it. It was in the window of every barrack. It was at the end of every street.

The Nakais were put in Block 22. Mr. Hamada and his wife were in Block 22 too, four barracks down, and Shig took that as a sign, though he did not believe in signs.

The camp gave him a job on the staff of the high school, which would open in October in barracks with no desks, teaching algebra to boys only three years younger than himself at nineteen dollars a month. He went for two weeks and then stopped going. He had signed up for correspondence courses from a university extension office back East, and the books came in the mail, and he did not open them. His mother asked him what he did all day. He said he was studying.

What he did all day was stand where he could see Mr. Hamada.

Mr. Hamada was on the landscaping crew. When the first snow came he was given a crew of old men and a truck, and they drove down to the Shoshone River and brought back rocks, river stones rounded and grey and speckled, and set them in the firebreak by the Block 22 mess hall, one at a time, a few each day. Shig stood at the corner of the laundry building with his hands in his pockets in the wind and watched him set them. He watched him at the mess hall, three tables away. He watched him at the Buddhist church on Sunday mornings, where the young people sat in folding chairs and chanted the Amida Sutra from the gatha books, *nyo ze ga mon, ichi ji butsu*, and where Mr. Hamada sometimes gave the talk when the ministers were busy, and where Shig did not chant but only looked. He walked behind him on the way back across the frozen mud, at a little distance, so as not to be a nuisance. In the evenings he stood in the dark outside the Hamadas' barrack and looked at the lit window.

Mr. Hamada knew. Everybody in Block 22 knew. The other young people made jokes about it and then stopped making jokes about it, because it was not funny, exactly, and because Mr. Hamada did not seem to mind. He said nothing to Shig all that fall. He nodded to him in the mess line. He let him stand at the corner of the laundry. He set his stones.

The winter came down hard. In January it was thirty below and the coal pile by the block ran low and the water froze in the pipes to the latrines, and the loyalty questions came in February, the two questions that every man in the camp argued over in the mess halls until the cooks put them out, and Shig's mother cried over the form at the table and signed it, and Shig signed his without reading it. He was looking out the window

at the stone garden, where Mr. Hamada was brushing snow off a rock with a whisk broom.

It was in March, on a raw grey afternoon with the wind going, that Mr. Hamada straightened up from the stones and looked at the corner of the laundry building and said, *Shig. Come here.*

Shig came. Mr. Hamada was holding a stone in both hands. His hands were red and cracked from the cold, and there was dirt in the creases of his knuckles.

Six months you've been standing there, he said in Japanese. *What are you looking at?*

Shig could not answer him.

This? Mr. Hamada set the stone down and held out his hands, front and back, as if he were showing Shig they were empty. *This is an old gardener. He has bad knees and one bad tooth. One of these days he'll be dead, and they'll burn him, and give my wife a box. You want to spend your life looking at that?*

He took a small book out of his coat, a sutra book with a cloth cover, and opened it to a place he had marked with a strip of newspaper, and read it to him in English, slowly, because Shig's Japanese was not good enough for sutras, and both of them knew it.

> *Those who have practised this meditation are said to have contemplated the bodies of all the Buddhas. Since they have meditated on Buddha's body, they will also see Buddha's mind. It is great compassion that is called Buddha's mind.*
>
> *— Amitâyur-dhyâna-sûtra § 18*

Whoever sees the teaching sees me, said Mr. Hamada. *Whoever looks at only me sees an old man with dirty hands.* He shut the book and gave it to Shig, and picked up the stone again, and went back to work.

Shig kept the book. He stood at the corner of the laundry building the next day, and the day after that.

III. Go Back

Block 22 · May to August 1943

In May the farmers around Powell came to the camp office looking for hands to thin sugar beets. They had been glad enough of the camp's labor at harvest the fall before, though in town the workers had not always been made welcome. Mr. Hamada signed up for the summer. He would be on a farm on the Shoshone flats below the mountain, he and five other men from the block, sleeping in a bunkhouse, hoeing beets from dawn to dark at a wage the farmer would set, until the season was over.

Shig went to the camp office the same afternoon and asked to be put on the same crew.

That evening Mr. Hamada came down the row to the Nakais' barrack and knocked on the door, which he had never done, and asked Mrs. Nakai's pardon, and asked if he could speak to her son outside.

They stood on the step. The mountain was black against the last of the light.

I went to the office, Mr. Hamada said. *I told them to take you off the list. You're not coming.*

Hamada-san—

Go back, he said. *Go back inside to your mother. Stay here.* And he went down the step and up the row in the dusk, and did not look around.

The truck left for Powell on a Tuesday morning. Shig did not go to see it off. He lay on his cot with his face to the tar paper and listened to it grind away down the camp road, and to the gravel, and then to nothing.

The summer was long. It was a hundred degrees in the barracks in July, and the wind brought the dust in through the cracks in the floorboards until there was a fine grey skin of it on the blanket every morning, and on the tin cup, and on the sutra book. The stone garden by the mess hall stood the way Mr. Hamada had left it, half finished, with a pile of river stones waiting at one end. Nobody touched them. Shig stood at the corner of the laundry building some days out of habit, and looked at them.

Mrs. Hamada said her husband was well. She said he did not write letters. He had never written letters.

He doesn't speak to me anymore, Shig said to his sister, who was eleven and did not understand what he meant. *He sent me away. He doesn't speak to me.*

He began reading the sutra book at night, by the one bulb, after his mother and sister were asleep behind their sheet. He read the English slowly, the way Mr. Hamada had read it to him. It was the story of a queen whose son had taken the throne and shut her up in a room in the palace and set a guard on the door, and of what happened to her there. He read one passage until the book fell open to it by itself, and he would sit on the edge of the cot with it open on his knee and look out the window at the mountain.

> *When Vaidehî was thus shut up in retirement she became afflicted by sorrow and distress. She began to do homage to Buddha from afar, looking towards the Mount Gridhrakûta.*
>
> *— Amitâyur-dhyâna-sûtra § 4*

He did not read the rest of it. He did not want to know what came next for the queen. He read that part and looked at the mountain, and Mr. Hamada was somewhere on the other side of it in the beets, and did not speak to him, and would not, and the fence was there, and the towers, and his father was in Montana writing on paper with holes in it, and the war would go on for ten years or forever, and he was twenty years old and had spent a year looking at one man's face and now could not see that either.

In August, in the third week, he thought for the first time: what is the use of going on with this.

Then he thought it every day.

IV. The Mountain

Heart Mountain · August 1943

By that summer the camp let the young people out in parties to hike to the mountain, with a pass from the office and a promise to be back before dark. The Boy Scouts went, and the Y.B.A., and boys from the high school in twos and threes with canteens and sandwiches from the mess hall. Shig got on the list for a Saturday with a group from Block 24 he did not know. He did not take a canteen.

They left at four in the morning through the gate and walked west across the flat in the dark, eight miles through the sage, and the mountain grew in front of them as the light came until it filled the sky. The others stopped to rest on the lower slopes, in the timber, and ate their sandwiches. Shig went on alone.

He climbed all morning. There was a trail of sorts and then there was not. He went up over loose rock and through stunted pines bent all one way by the wind, and then out onto the bare grey limestone of the summit, with the wind pushing at him, and walked to the edge of the north face, where the rock broke off and went straight down for a very long way.

He could see everything from there. He could see the whole Big Horn Basin laid out yellow and green, and the river, and the checkerboard of fields around Powell, and in the middle of the flat, small and square and very neat, the camp. The rows of barracks. The fence. The smoke of the hospital chimney going straight up and then bending. He found Block 22. He thought he could see the mess hall, and the little grey pile of stones beside it.

He stood there a long time. He was not frightened. He felt nothing very much, which was the worst of it. He thought about his mother and sister, and that it would be hard on them, and that they would be better off. He thought about Mr. Hamada in a beet field somewhere down there in the checkerboard with a hoe, not thinking about him. He took the sutra book out of his shirt and held it. He put one foot forward to the edge.

Then the light changed.

The light came from in front of him, out over the drop, where there was nothing but air, and it was the color of the sun through a jar of honey, and it was Mr. Hamada. He was standing in the air off the edge of the rock, as easily as he had stood in the firebreak by the mess hall, in his khaki shirt with the sleeves rolled, with the light coming from him so that it hurt to look and Shig could not stop looking. His face was the face Shig had watched for a year. It was the same face and it was not the same at all.

Shig's sorrow went out of him. It went the way water goes out of a bucket when you turn the bucket over, all at once, and he stood empty on the edge of the rock, and then the other thing came pouring in where the sorrow had been, so fast that it hurt, like water into dry ground that has not had rain all summer, faster than the ground can take it.

Mr. Hamada held out his hand to him across the drop, the dirty cracked hand with the soil in the knuckles.

Shig, he said. *Come. Don't be afraid. Look at me. I'll pull you out, the way we pulled the trucks out of the gumbo.*

Come. Don't be afraid. Look at me. I'll bring you out, the way the sun comes out after the eclipse.

Come. Don't be afraid. Look at me. I'll bring you out, the way the moon comes out of the shadow.

Shig thought: he has come. He speaks to me. He says come. And then he thought: but how do I go? There is no path. There was no path. There was the edge of the rock and then a long way down. He looked at Mr. Hamada and not at the drop, and stepped off.

This is the part of it that they tell in Block 22, and there are people who will tell you they saw it, from the camp, eight miles off. A woman hanging laundry behind Block 27 who said she saw a spark come off the top of the mountain and go out over the basin, slow, like a bird with the sun on it. A boy on the irrigation canal crew who said it was a man, walking. Shig himself never said much. He said he walked on the air the way you walk down a flight of stairs in the dark in your own house, without looking, because you know they are there. He said that somewhere over

the canal, with the whole basin turning under him, he stopped being glad, which he had been, more glad than he had ever been in his life, and that the gladness went quiet, and then it went still, and then there was only the stillness, very large, with everything in it, the camp and the fence and the beets and his father in Montana and the queen in her room and the mountain, and nothing left over that was Shig to want any of it.

He came down in a beet field on the Shoshone flats in the middle of the afternoon, between two rows, and stood up.

Mr. Hamada was at the end of the row with his hoe. He was sunburned, and his shirt was black with sweat down the back, and he had dirt to the elbows. He looked at Shig for a while. Then he took off his hat and wiped his forehead with his sleeve, and Shig bowed to him, there in the beets, all the way down, the way he had seen his grandfather bow at the temple when he was a little boy, and stayed down a long time.

When he straightened up he found he had the sutra book still in his hand. It had fallen open where it always did, and he turned the pages past that place, to the end, and read the part he had not wanted to read, about what happened to the queen.

> *With her mind filled with joy she praised them, saying: 'Never have I seen such a wonder!' Instantaneously she became wholly and fully enlightened, and attained a spirit of resignation, prepared to endure whatever consequences might yet arise.*
>
> *— Amitâyur-dhyâna-sûtra § 31*

The farmer came out from the house at suppertime and found an extra Japanese boy in his field without a pass and was angry about it, and then confused, because the boy said he had come from the camp that morning and the farmer had been on the road all day and seen nobody. He drove him back to the gate in the pickup with Mr. Hamada riding along in the bed to vouch for him. The M.P. at the gate wrote it up as a hiker who had come down the wrong side of the mountain. The hiking party from Block 24 had already reported him missing. They had looked for him on the

summit for an hour, and found nothing but his footprints in the dust, going to the edge of the north face, and stopping.

V. Shinjin

Block 22 · September 1943 and after

Mr. Hamada came back from the beets in September with his wages in an envelope and finished the stone garden by the mess hall before the snow. Shig helped him. He did not stand at the corner of the laundry anymore. He carried the stones, and set them where he was told, and when Mr. Hamada was not there he went on with it by himself and did not seem to notice the difference. He went back to teaching algebra. He opened the correspondence books.

At the Buddhist church that winter, on a Sunday when the ministers asked Mr. Hamada to give the talk, he spoke about *shinjin*, the true entrusting, which is the heart of the Shin teaching and the hardest thing in it to explain. He did not explain it. He said there were people who studied it for fifty years and people who knew it in one afternoon, and that the second kind were rarer, and that he had known only one of them. He did not say who. Nobody in Block 22 needed him to.

• • •

The camp closed in November 1945. Those who were left were given twenty-five dollars and a train ticket, and the barracks were sold off for lumber to homesteaders, and the wind came over the flat and filled in the streets with sage.

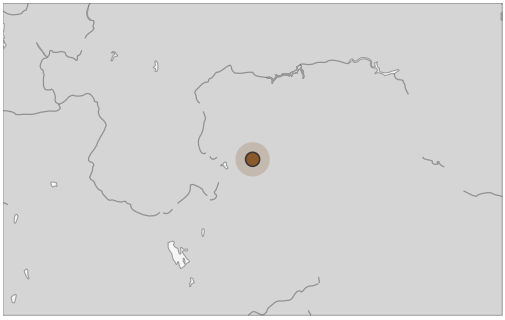
The stone garden by the Block 22 mess hall was too much trouble for anybody to haul away. For a while, people who drove out from Powell to look at the place where the camp had been could still find it if they knew where to look: a low ring of grey river stones in the sage, set close, each one turned so that its best face was up. The mountain stood behind it in the west, the way it always had, at the end of what had been the street.

Background

The verse

> *The Bhikshu, full of delight, who is calm in the doctrine of Buddha will reach the quiet place (Nirvana), cessation of natural desires, and happiness.*
>
> Dhammapada 381, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the young Brahmin Vakkali is so taken with the Buddha's physical beauty that he becomes a monk only to be able to look at him, and gives up study and meditation to do nothing else. The Buddha waits, then tells him: "What shall it profit you to look upon this body? Whoever sees the Dhamma sees me." Vakkali still cannot leave him, so at the start of the rains the Buddha sends him away. After three months apart, believing the Teacher will never speak to him again, Vakkali climbs Vulture's Peak to throw himself off. The Buddha sends a radiant image of himself, speaks the verse, and stretches out his hand: "Come, Vakkali, do not fear, look upon the Realised One." Vakkali springs into the air toward him, reaches awakening in flight, and comes down at the Teacher's feet. He was later named foremost among those inclined to faith. Read the full commentary story, or the Vakkali Sutta (SN 22.87), where the Buddha tells him, "One who sees the teaching sees me." The scripture quoted in the story is the Contemplation Sutra, one of the three Pure Land sutras that Shin Buddhists hold as their scripture. It tells how Queen Vaidehī, imprisoned by her son, prayed toward Vulture's Peak, and how the Buddha came to her there.



Heart Mountain, Wyoming

Heart Mountain, Wyoming, 1942–1943

After Pearl Harbor, the F.B.I. arrested Issei community leaders, Buddhist priests among them, and held them in Justice Department camps such as Fort Missoula in Montana. Under Executive Order 9066, some 120,000 people of Japanese ancestry on the West Coast were then removed from their homes. Many from Los Angeles

County were held first at the Pomona Assembly Center on the county fairgrounds, and most of them were sent on to the Heart Mountain Relocation Center. The first inmates arrived there on August 12, 1942. The camp held 10,767 people at its peak in January 1943, which made it the third-largest town in Wyoming. Its barracks stood inside a barbed-wire fence with nine guard towers, on a sagebrush flat between Cody and Powell, with Heart Mountain about eight miles to the west. Winter lows reached about thirty below zero. Early in 1943 the government's "loyalty questionnaire" divided the camp, and in 1944 the Heart Mountain Fair Play Committee organized a draft resistance that ended in the largest mass trial in Wyoming history.

About two-thirds of Heart Mountain's people were Buddhist. In 1942 the camp's eight priests, of several sects, formed the Heart Mountain Buddhist Federation, and services, Sunday school and O-Bon were held in a makeshift church. Hundreds of inmates left the camp on seasonal leave to work the sugar beet harvest in Wyoming and Montana, where farmers needed their labor and townspeople often met them with hostility. Inmates also went out in hiking parties to the mountain. The camp closed on November 10, 1945. Most of the barracks were sold and hauled away, and the site is now a National Historic Landmark with an interpretive center. Block 22, the Nakai and Hamada families and the stone garden are invented.

After the story of the Elder Vakkali from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 381). The original. Scripture from the Amitâyur-dhyâna-sûtra, tr. J. Takakusu, in *Buddhist Mahâyâna Texts*, Sacred Books of the East vol. 49 (1894). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

25.12

The Rock Spring

The Moon doth with delight
Look round her when the heavens are bare;
— William Wordsworth, Ode: Intimations of Immortality, II (1807)

As it was given me, at Cassadaga.

I. The Dinner Pail

Pomfret, Chautauqua County · 1840

Annis Wheelock, before she was anybody, was the hired girl on Sumner Hale's farm on the ridge above the Cassadaga lakes. She was seventeen. She milked, churned, scrubbed, carried, and in haying time took the men their dinners in the field and then went back for her own, which was corn bread and a piece of salt pork in a tin pail with a cloth over it, set aside for her on the back of the stove. Sumner Hale was the richest man in the town of Pomfret. He gave a great deal away, at the church and on the roads, with his name on it, and he was proud of what he gave.

One noon in July, coming back across the field for her pail, Annis met an old man on the road. He was a tin peddler by the look of his pack, but he had no tin in it, and he had a tin cup in his hand with nothing in it either. He did not ask for anything. When she said, *Have you not had your dinner?* he looked at her a long time and said, *I expect to have it, daughter.*

Then wait, said Annis.

She ran to the house. The cook had kept her pail. She ran back with it and gave him all of it, the corn bread and the pork. She remembered all her life what she was thinking while she ran. That when she had wanted

to give anything, she had never had anything to give, and when she had anything, there had been nobody to give it to, and today there were both at once. As she put the pail in his hands she said a thing she had not known she was going to say. *I hope I never in my life have to say there isn't any.*

So be it, said the old man, and ate, and went on down the road toward Fredonia, and nobody saw him after.

The hired man, who was forking hay in the barn, swore afterward that a voice in the empty mow cried out three times, *Well given! Well given! Well given!* and that he looked and there was nobody in the mow but the swallows. He told it at supper. Sumner Hale heard it and was put out, because he had given away a great deal in his life and no voice had ever called out from a haymow for him.

He called Annis into the front room. *I'll give you a dollar for that dinner,* he said. She said it was not for sale. He went to five, and to ten, and at last to a hundred dollars in gold, which was more than she would earn in five years, and she said it was not for sale. *Then sell me the good of it,* said Sumner Hale. *Whatever you got by it. A hundred dollars.*

Annis did not know what to say to that, so she went out and found the old man, who was sitting under a beech tree on the Fredonia road, and asked him.

If you light your lantern, the old man said, *and every house on this road comes and lights its lantern off yours and carries it home, is there less light in yours?*

There's more light on the road, said Annis.

That's all it is, said the old man.

So she went back and told Sumner Hale he could have the good of her dinner and welcome, but she would not take his money for it, and he said in that case he would not have her work for him with her hands anymore. He paid for her schooling at the Fredonia Academy. She taught school after. She married and was widowed young. In 1850, when the rappings were going all over western New York, she sat in a circle for the first time and found that she could see. The Spiritualists called her a clairvoyant.

She could see a long way, and into rooms she was not in, and sometimes, she said, a little way into what had been.

And from that day in the hayfield until the day she died, it was said, Annis Wheelock never once had to say there wasn't any. Children came to her door and asked for bread, and she lifted the cloth on the bread bowl, and there was bread. Her hired girls swore to it. One of them said she had looked into the bowl herself before the cloth went on, and it was empty.

II. The Season

The Hale farm and the camp grounds · June–August 1897

By the summer of 1897 Annis Wheelock was seventy-four, and her gift was the most famous in the camp at Cassadaga. She came every season for the June picnic and stayed until the grapes were picked. Old Sumner Hale was dead thirty years. That spring, sitting in her parlor in Buffalo with her eyes shut, she had looked for him, the way she sometimes looked for people, and found him. He was standing behind a small boy in a grape vineyard on the ridge above the lake, with his hand on the boy's head. The boy was his grandson, Hiram Hale's youngest, and his name was Sumner too. He would be seven in July.

She wrote to Hiram Hale, whom she had known since he was a baby, and he wrote back that he would count it an honor to have her for the season. So she boarded that summer at the Hale farm and was driven down to the camp each morning in the Hales' democrat wagon, past the gate where the ticket man took a quarter from visitors and touched his hat to her. She sat on the platform of the Auditorium under the great roof on its posts, with the curtains drawn up and the lake shining beyond. She gave sittings in the parlor of the Grand Hotel. She heard Mrs. Twing and Mr. Hull, and the young man from Ceylon, in white, who spoke about the Buddha. In the evenings she sat on the Hales' porch with her eyes shut, and the Hales were very careful to be quiet, and Hiram's wife Ruth brought her tea and saw that her shawl stayed on.

Little Sumner watched her. He was a thin, grave, fair-haired boy with his hair still in long curls to his collar, the way his mother liked it. He sat on the porch step at her feet in the evenings and did not fidget, and once, when she opened her eyes, he said, *Who was the man with the tin cup?* and she looked at him a long while and did not answer.

When the camp closed on the twenty-ninth of August, Hiram Hale brought out what he had laid by for her: a ten-dollar gold piece, a crock of honey, two gallons of maple syrup from the spring sugaring, and the first baskets of Concords off the south slope. He set them at her feet on the porch.

I have no use for them, Hiram, said Annis.

It's what's done, Mrs. Wheelock. For a season's board, the other way around.

I have no use for them.

Why not?

I have nobody to see to me, said Annis. *My eyes are going and my legs are gone. I need somebody to fetch and carry.*

Then take Hi, said Hiram. Hi was twelve and strong.

I don't want Hi.

Hiram looked at her, and then at the porch step. *Then take Sumner.*

Yes, said Annis. *Him.*

Ruth Hale cried, but she said yes, because it was Mrs. Wheelock and because it was only to the camp ground, three miles off, where Annis kept a cottage by the lake and wintered when the weather allowed. And the next morning, because a boy going out to work should look like a boy, Ruth took Sumner down to the barber in Cassadaga village to have his curls cut off for the first time. The barber put him up on a board across the arms of the chair. Ruth said afterward that she was watching his face in the glass when the scissors went through the first curl, and that his face changed. It did not change much. It was only that he looked, all at once, as if he had heard his name called from a long way off and had answered. By the time the barber had swept the curls into a paper for her to keep, it was done, whatever it was. Mrs. Wheelock said so as soon as they came in at the gate. She said he had come out all at once, without

any developing at all, the way she had heard of only once or twice in fifty years, and that he could see farther already than she could.

She stayed at the farm a fortnight more. Then she and the boy went down to the cottage on the grounds.

III. The Rock Spring

Saratoga Springs · September 1897

THE CAMP WAS EMPTY BY THEN. THE HOTELS WERE SHUT, THE boats pulled up, the Auditorium curtains let down and tied. The two of them had the grounds nearly to themselves. Annis kept her hours as she always had. She sat up half the night on the cottage porch, walking up and down it when her legs allowed, sitting for the spirits, and by the middle of September she had brought on the dyspepsia that came on her every fall. She went yellow and could not keep her supper. Sumner found her on the porch in the gray of the morning with her hand pressed under her ribs.

What ails you, Mrs. Wheelock?

My old trouble.

Have you had it before?

Many a time.

What cures it?

She smiled. *Water from the Rock Spring at Saratoga, child. I drank it when I was a girl and it cured me, and nothing else ever has.*

Then I'll fetch you some.

She looked at him. Saratoga was three hundred miles away across the state. *Can you?*

Yes, ma'am.

The spring belongs to a man named Asa Pennock now, she said. *He knew me once. Tell him your errand, and ask him for a jar of water for medicine.*

Sumner took a quart Mason jar off the pantry shelf and went out of the cottage. That is all anyone on the grounds saw of it. The man who kept the South Park House, which stayed open the year round, said he saw the boy cross the park toward the lake at a little after five in the morning. In

Saratoga, a milkman on his route said he saw a fair-haired boy with a jar come down out of the air and light on the roof of the pump house at the Rock Spring as the sun came up. He told it for the rest of his life.

• • •

The Rock Spring lay in a little ravine at the edge of the town, below the bluff, where the water had come up out of the ground since before there was a town and the Mohawk had come to it before there were any white men at all. Asa Pennock had bought the ground in the eighties, drilled it and sunk his pipes. He pumped the gas out of the water and sold it in iron cylinders to the soda fountains of New York, Boston and Philadelphia. It was good business. The water that had once come up in the basin by itself now came up only when his pumps let it, and he had built a pump house over the place and capped the old spring with an iron bell, and there was a padlock on the door. Half the old springs of Saratoga had gone dry that way in ten years. People complained. Pennock was a big, florid, short-tempered man who had made his money hard and liked to stand in his own doorway in the morning and look at it.

He was standing in the doorway that morning when the boy lit on his roof. He heard the small boots on the shingles over his head.

Here's some camp-meeting brat walking around on top of me, he said to his engineer. *Come for water, I suppose. Well, he won't get it.* And he went out and locked the pump-house door behind him and stood in front of it with his arms folded.

Sumner climbed down and stood in front of him in the wet grass.

Mr. Pennock, he said, *I've come for a jar of water from the Rock Spring. It's for medicine. Mrs. Annis Wheelock sent me. She says you knew her.*

Did she. Pennock looked down at him. *There's the Hudson River twelve miles east of here, boy, running down to the sea. Plenty of water in it. Go dip your jar in that.*

She said this water and no other, said Sumner. *So I'll take this. If you can stop me, stop me.*

Pennock laughed. *If you're man enough to get it, take it.*

You're sure?

Take it if you can.

You're sure? said Sumner a third time, and Pennock, who was beginning not to like the way the boy looked at him, said he was sure.

What Sumner did then was told on the camp grounds afterward by people who said they had it from the other side, and they told it plainly, and so it is set down here. He went up. He went up through the spheres, one after another, the way you would go down a street knocking on doors. He went to the spirits who keep near the earth, and to the ones above them, and above those, all the way up through the bright ones to the edge of where anything can be told about at all, and at every door he said the same thing. *There's going to be a contest between me and Asa Pennock at the Rock Spring at Saratoga. Come down and see who wins.* And they came. They came down over the ravine at sunrise until the air above it was packed with them, close as shot poured into a measure.

Nobody in Saratoga could see them. But every night clerk on Broadway remembered that morning. In the great empty parlors of the hotels, the pianos sounded a note by themselves. On every door along Circular Street there came a knock, and when people opened, there was nobody on the step, and still the knocking went on, door after door, as if a crowd too big for the street were passing by. The milkman's horse would not go another step and stood in the road with its ears back.

Then the boy asked Pennock a fourth time, in front of all of them, and Pennock said what he had said before. And the milkman said that for the space of a breath the boy was as tall as the elms on Broadway, so tall his head was in the sun while the ravine was still in shadow. He came down on the roof of the pump house with one foot. The roof folded under him like a wet glove under a boot heel. The iron bell over the old spring split along its seam. Water came up through every seam, joint and bolt hole in the place, in jets as tall as the elms, a dozen of them, white, roaring, smelling of iron, the way Saratoga's spouting springs had gone up in the old days before the pumps. The boy, standing in the air above all of it, held out his Mason jar and filled it.

IV. Mr. Pennock

The camp ground, Lily Dale · the same day and the next

SUMNER WAS ON THE COTTAGE PORCH BY NOON. HE UNscrewed the jar and put it in Mrs. Wheelock's hands. *Drink it, ma'am.*

Asa Pennock was a day behind him. He took the morning train to Albany, then the New York Central west to Buffalo, and changed twice more. He got down at the Lily Dale station on the evening of the next day with his eyes red as sumac and his collar sprung, and walked into the closed camp ground asking at every cottage for Mrs. Wheelock. He had shut down his pumps and come straight on. In the train, he had told the conductor, he had decided he would either wring the boy's neck or carry him to Niagara and throw him over the Falls, he had not yet decided which.

Annis had not drunk the water yet. She was sitting on the porch with the jar in her lap. Pennock stood at the foot of her steps and took off his hat, because he could not help it, he had known her when he was young. *Mrs. Wheelock,* he said, *that boy of yours took my water without my leave. Don't drink it.*

Sumner, said Annis, *is that so?*

No, ma'am, said the boy. *Mr. Pennock gave it to me. He said so three times.*

Annis knew that the boy could not lie. So she unscrewed the jar and drank. It was cold and tasted of iron, the way it had when she was a girl, and almost at once she felt the knot under her ribs let go.

He made a fool of me, said Pennock. *He brought down I don't know what, the whole sky, and stood on my roof, and made a fool of me before the whole town. I'll have satisfaction for it.*

Asa, said Annis, *you can't fight that child. You'd do better to beg his pardon and go home.* And she said to him what was written:

> *Out of the mouth of babes and sucklings hast thou ordained strength because of thine enemies, that thou mightest still the enemy and the avenger.*
>
> *— Psalm 8:2*

Pennock already knew it, of course. He had known it on his roof. He had come three hundred miles only because he had been shamed, and a shamed man has to do something. He stood at the foot of the steps a while with his hat in his hands. Then he begged the boy's pardon, and shook his hand, a great hairy hand around a small one.

Another time, he said, *don't you trouble to come yourself. You send me a wire. I'll put the water on the express myself, and it won't cost you a cent.*

Then he walked back through the empty grounds to the station and took the night train east.

V. The Lyceum

Library Hall and the Grand Hotel · opening week, July 1898

The camp opened the next summer on the fifteenth of July. Annis came down to the Grand Hotel on the first afternoon, on the boy's arm, to pay her respects to Mrs. Electa Barnard.

Mrs. Barnard was eighty-four, the oldest trance speaker in the movement and the one people came farthest to hear. She had been on the platform since the year after the rappings, in every hall from Boston to San Francisco. She was a small, wide old woman in black silk, almost blind, and off the platform she hardly spoke at all. On the platform, when the spirits had her, her voice filled the Auditorium to the back rows and out onto the lake. People said there was nothing she did not know. That afternoon she was sitting on the long veranda of the Grand Hotel in a wicker chair with her hands folded on her cane, and everyone who came in at the gate came up the steps to her.

The mediums and lecturers and patrons on the veranda made a great deal of Annis, and then of the boy. Some of them had heard about the Rock Spring and did not believe it, and some had not heard. They patted his cropped head. A test medium from Cleveland took hold of his ear between two fingers and gave it a shake. *Well, little medium, aren't you homesick? Don't you want to go home to your mama?* A lecturer from Toledo tweaked the other ear. The boy stood there between them and let them, with his hands at his sides.

Mrs. Barnard turned her face toward the sound. She thought that they were picking up a copperhead by the neck and did not know it. She thought that it was time they knew.

Orrin, she said, to Mr. Orrin Bell, who was Conductor of the Children's Lyceum and stood always near her chair to do what she asked. *My feet are bad. I should like to bathe them tonight in water from the Rock Spring at Saratoga. Ask the Lyceum children to fetch it.*

Mr. Bell went down to Library Hall, where the Lyceum met every morning of the season and had met that first morning, a hundred and forty children in their twelve groups, and he called them together. The Lyceum went by groups as the old manual laid it down. The littlest were Fountain Group, who wore red badges. Then came Stream, River, Lake, Sea, Ocean, Shore, Beacon, Banner, Star and Excelsior, and at the top the big boys and girls of Liberty Group, in white. Mr. Bell went to the eldest boy of Liberty Group first.

Mrs. Barnard wishes to bathe her feet tonight in water from the Rock Spring at Saratoga. Will you fetch it?

I can't, sir, said the boy, and went red.

Mr. Bell asked them all, group by group, down through Excelsior, Star, Banner and the rest. Every one of them said they could not. Some of them, it was said afterward, could have gone. There were children in that Lyceum who had come out young and could do things, and their mothers knew it. They said no anyway, because they knew whose errand it was. The ones who could not have gone said no because they could not.

Sumner Hale was the youngest in Fountain Group, and so the last in the room. Mr. Bell came to him.

Mrs. Barnard wishes—

If Mrs. Barnard wants it, I'll fetch it, said Sumner, and went up to the hotel and stood in front of her chair. *Ma'am, they tell me you want water from the Rock Spring.*

Yes, Sumner.

The great ice-water pitcher stood on a table in the hotel parlor, where it had stood since Mrs. Lavinia Pettibone of Titusville, whose husband had struck oil on Pithole Creek, gave it to the camp. It was silver-plate

gilded all over, chased with lilies, and held two gallons, and full it took two men to lift it. Sumner took it off the table. He did not trouble to put it on his shoulder. He took it by the rim in one hand and let it hang, and went out through the parlor door and down the veranda steps. The people on the veranda watched him go up over the lawn, out over the lake and away east above the trees, the pitcher swinging from his hand and catching the sun.

At Saratoga, Asa Pennock saw him coming while he was still a long way off. He came out of his new pump house at a run, bareheaded, and met the boy in the ravine and took the pitcher out of his hand.

Now why, he said, *when you've got a man like me in the world, would you come yourself? Why didn't you wire?* He filled the pitcher at the spring with his own hands, and settled it on his own shoulder. *You go on ahead, son. I'll carry it.*

Stay where you are, Mr. Pennock, said Sumner. *Mrs. Barnard sent me.* He took the pitcher back by the rim and went up.

Mrs. Barnard could not see him come. But she lifted her face on the veranda as if she could, and said to the people around her, *Look at him. He comes like a wild goose coming in to the water.* They looked. He came down over the lake out of the evening with the gilt pitcher swinging from his hand, lit on the lawn, carried it up the steps without spilling a drop, and set it at her feet.

How old are you, Sumner? said Mrs. Barnard.

Seven, ma'am. Eight on Wednesday.

Then on Sunday you'll sit on the platform, said Mrs. Barnard. *With the mediums.*

The people on the veranda were very quiet. Nobody sat on the platform of the Auditorium at Cassadaga but the speakers and the chairman and the tested mediums whose names were printed in the program. They said afterward that in all the years of the camp only two children had ever been given a chair there as mediums in their own right. One was a little girl from Ohio in the early days, whose name nobody could agree on. The other was Sumner Hale.

VI. The Platform

The Auditorium · Sunday, July 1898

On Sunday the Auditorium was full, fifteen hundred people on the benches and more standing on the grass beyond the posts with the curtains rolled up and the lake bright behind them. The band played. The speakers came up onto the platform and took their chairs, and the boy came up with them in a clean collar, with his red Fountain badge pinned to his jacket, and sat in a chair that was too big for him. His feet did not reach the floor.

In Library Hall that week there was no other talk among the mediums. They had all seen the pitcher come in over the lake, or knew someone who had. A medium from Cleveland, the same one who had shaken the boy's ear on the veranda, said she had been in the work thirty-one years and had never seen a power like it. Nobody had. They were still saying it when Mrs. Barnard came in on her cane one morning to hear the Lyceum, and asked them what they were talking about, and they told her.

She sat down. She was quiet a long time. Then she said that such a power was given to any child, any child at all, who came to it whole and gave it everything he had. That was all she said in her own voice. Then, because she was old and had been a schoolteacher in Vermont before ever she heard a rap, she said a piece of a poem that the Lyceum children all knew, and the mediums knew it too. It was the poem by Mr. Wordsworth about the child who comes trailing clouds of glory, the one Spiritualists had loved since before there were Spiritualists, and she said the part that is spoken to the child.

Thou, whose exterior semblance doth belie
Thy Soul's immensity;
Thou best Philosopher, who yet dost keep
Thy heritage, thou Eye among the blind,
That, deaf and silent, read'st the eternal deep,
Haunted for ever by the eternal mind,—
Mighty Prophet! Seer blest!
On whom those truths do rest,
Which we are toiling all our lives to find,

— William Wordsworth, Ode: Intimations of Immortality, VIII (1807)

The medium from Cleveland put her hand up to her mouth. A good many of the people in Library Hall went home from the camp that summer different from the way they had come, and some of them could have said why.

• • •

Annis Wheelock lived three more summers. Sumner stayed with her and saw to her, fetching and carrying. In the evenings he sat on the step of the cottage porch at her feet while she sat with her eyes shut. She told him once, near the end, that his grandfather was standing behind him, as he had been the first time she saw him, with his hand on the boy's head. Sumner said he knew. She said they were the same two as always, the old man and the girl with the pail, and she did not say any more about it.

Every July after that, as long as the camp ran on the old lines and for some years after, a crate came up on the express to the Lily Dale station from Saratoga. It held twelve quart bottles packed in straw, and it was stenciled ROCK SPRING, with a tag wired to the slats in a big rough hand, and the tag always said the same thing. *For the Hale boy. No charge.*

Background

The verse

> *He who, even as a young Bhikshu, applies himself to the doctrine of Buddha, brightens up this world, like the moon when free from clouds.*
>
> Dhammapada 382, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a poor grass-carrier named Annabhāra gives his only meal to a solitary buddha and wishes never again to hear the word "there isn't." His rich employer, Sumana, tries to buy the merit of the gift. The solitary buddha compares merit to a lamp that lights a whole village without growing less, so Annabhāra gives it away freely and is made rich. Reborn as Anuruddha, the Buddha's cousin, he grows up so sheltered that when his mother sends him an empty covered bowl, the gods fill it with cakes. As a monk he becomes foremost in the divine eye. Seeing that his old friend Sumana has been reborn as a boy, he takes the child as his novice, and the boy becomes an arahat as his hair is cut. When Anuruddha falls ill, the seven-year-old flies to Lake Anotatta for water. The nāga king Paṇṇaka covers the lake with his hood and tells him to fetch water from the Ganges. The boy calls the gods of every heaven to witness, grows huge, treads on the nāga's hood, and fills his jar from the jets that spring up. The nāga pursues him, is told to beg the boy's pardon, and becomes his servant. Later, when monks tweak the novice's ears, the Buddha asks for water from Anotatta to bathe his feet. Of five hundred novices only the youngest goes, carrying a vast golden vessel and refusing the nāga's offer to carry it. The Buddha ordains him on the spot at the age of seven. Read the full commentary story.

Lily Dale, New York

Cassadaga and Saratoga, 1897

Lily Dale, on Upper Cassadaga Lake in Chautauqua County, was incorporated in 1879 as the Cassadaga Lake Free Association, a summer camp for Spiritualists and freethinkers. By the 1890s its season ran from mid-July to the end of August, with

lectures and mediums in an open-sided Auditorium that seated about fifteen hundred, hotels, a library, and a Children's Lyceum that met each morning in Library Hall. The Lyceums followed the manual written by Andrew Jackson Davis in the 1860s, which sorted children into twelve groups named from the youngest up: Fountain, Stream, River, Lake, Sea, Ocean, Shore, Beacon, Banner, Star, Excelsior and Liberty, each with its own badge color. Women spoke from the platform on equal terms with men, and suffragists including Susan B. Anthony came to speak. In 1897 the Buddhist reformer Anagarika Dharmapala of Ceylon was among the season's speakers. The National Spiritualist Association, founded in 1893, has its headquarters there today.

Saratoga Springs, whose mineral springs the Mohawk had used long before European settlement, was by then the country's grandest spa, with its waters bottled and sold as cures for dyspepsia and much else. By the 1880s more than two hundred wells had been drilled around the town, most of them to extract carbonic acid gas for the soda fountains of the cities, and the pumping stopped the flow of many springs. In 1908 the state passed laws against the pumping, and the springs were taken into a state reservation, now Saratoga Spa State Park.

After the story of the novice Sumana from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 382). The original. Scripture from the King James Version and William Wordsworth's Ode: Intimations of Immortality (1807). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

Chapter 26

The Brahmana

26.1

Come In, Saints

> *Wherefore, brethren, giue rather diligence to make your calling and election sure.*
> *— 2 Peter 1:10 (Geneva Bible)*

As it was spoken before the church, at Newark on Pesayak River.

I. The Relation

Newark, East New Jersey · the Lord's day, February 1667/8

THE RELATION OF HOPESTILL AMBLER, PLANTER, MADE BEFORE the church at the noon exercise, he desiring to be received into full communion. Taken down as near his own words as the clerk could keep up, the room being cold and the ink thick.

Brethren, I will be short, for I have tried this before and been long and it came to nothing.

I was born in Norfolk and came over a child in the year 1638 with the company that sat down at Quinnipiac, and I have lived all my life since among the people of God, at New Haven and then at Branford, and now here. I have sat under the best preaching in the world. I have seen men and women stand where I stand now and tell how the Lord broke them and bound them up, and the tears ran down my face, and I went home and could find no such thing in myself. Not the breaking and not the binding. Thirty years. I have been a good neighbor, I hope, and paid my rates. I am not a saint. I never could say I was.

But I will tell you what I can say, which is that I have loved the saints. I have loved them more than my meat. When I was a boy at New Haven and a member went by in the street, I would stand and look after him as you would look after a ship going out with all its canvas. I could not help

it. I did not know what they had, but I knew it was the one thing worth the having.

You know why we came here. When the King's charter gave our colony to Connecticut, and the Connecticut way was to make every man a freeman whether he was in covenant or no, and the synod had set up the halfway way of baptizing the children of those who had never owned the covenant themselves, Mr. Pierson said we must go out again into the wilderness and keep the old order or lose it, and we came. We left our houses. I left a house at Branford I built with these hands, the chimney still warm, and the church carried its book in a chest. We came here to make a town where none but members of the churches should be freemen or bear office. A town of saints.

And I came, who was not one.

II. The Noon Table

The house lot nearest the meeting-house · summer and autumn 1667

The Lord gave me the lot nearest the meeting-house. I did not ask for it. It fell to me by the draw, and I took it for a sign of what I was to do, which was to feed people.

Between the morning exercise and the afternoon, the families that live near go home to their dinners, but there are those whose lots lie out toward the great meadows and over the brook, and the young men who have no house yet, and they used to sit in the meeting-house and eat cold bread. So from the first Lord's day in July I set my table for them. My wife and I fed sixteen. Pottage, and rye-and-Indian bread, and what fish the river gave, and in the fall venison the Indians sold us, and beer.

Brethren, you know how I greeted them. Some of you were among the sixteen. I stood at my door and I said: *Come in, saints. Sit down, saints. Saints, will you have more?* I said it to every one. I said it to Sergeant Ruggles, who gave his relation at Branford in 1644 and has walked with God ever since, and I said it to the Lacey boy, who is eighteen and who I know for a fact went over to the Dutch at Bergen in August and came back merry. I said it to all of them alike. I could not see what the Lord

sees and I did not try. When a man sat down at my table I saw a saint, because I wanted so much for there to be saints, and I could not bear to think the next one in my door was not.

I thought it was a kindness. It was not received as one.

The young men went red. They looked into their pottage. I learned afterward that they said to one another, going back across the lot, *Old Ambler thinks we are of the elect. Old Ambler will find out.* One of them said it was like being called Captain when you have never been to sea. And the old members, the ones who had given their relations and been received, they did not go red, but they went quiet, and I learned afterward what they said too, which was: *He calls us saints and he calls the Lacey boy a saint in the same breath. He has no discerning.* One said I made the word cheap.

In October they stopped coming. Not all at once. One Lord's day there were twelve, then nine, then on the first Lord's day in November there was no one, and my wife had a pottage for sixteen on the fire, and we sat at the table the two of us and looked at the benches, and I could see through the window into the meeting-house, where they were sitting in their coats eating cold bread off their knees, with the frost on the inside of the glass.

I am not ashamed to tell you I wept. I had thought, if I could not be one, I could at least feed them. And now I could not even do that.

III. Goodwife Bray

Her house by the Watering Place · November 1667

So I went to Goodwife Bray. You all know why. She is the oldest woman in this town, past seventy-nine. She was the midwife at Branford twenty years and at New Haven before that. There is hardly a soul here under thirty that she did not catch in her two hands, and she says she can tell a man's whole disposition by the way he came. She does not speak in meeting, as women may not, and she does not need to.

I told her the whole of it. She heard me through, shelling beans into her apron. Then she asked me why I said it. I said I did not know. I said,

because I love them. Because it is the only thing in the world I want, and I want it so much I see it everywhere.

She said, *Go home and set the table.*

The next Lord's day, between the exercises, she put on her hood and walked across the lot to the meeting-house, slow, on her stick, and went in where the sixteen were eating their cold bread, and stood in front of them. Some of you were there. I was not. This is what was told me, and if I have it wrong the brethren who were there will set me right.

She said, *Which of you will tell me why you have left Hopestill Ambler's table for this?*

And the young men told her: he calls us saints, and we are not, and it shames us. And the old members told her: he calls us saints, and he calls them saints, and he cannot tell the difference, and it is no honor to be praised by a man who praises everybody.

She said, *Did any of you think he was mocking you?* No, they said. *Did any of you think he was lying?* No. *Then what is it?* And nobody could answer.

Then she told them. She said, *The church takes in a member upon the judgment of charity. You know that. You old men know it best of anyone, you who were taken in upon it. Not one of you was seen into by the elders down to the bottom. They heard your relation and judged in charity that the work was true, because only God sees the heart. That is all Hopestill Ambler does. He judges in charity, and the only difference between him and the elders is that he does it all the way. There is no fault in that. I have known him since he was eleven years old, and I tell you that man's love for the saints has no bottom to it. It is the one thing in him that has no bottom.*

Then she turned on the young men. *And you. You go red because he calls you what you are not. Well, then. I did not catch you in my hands to see you sit on a bench and eat cold bread because a good man thinks too well of you. Make him right. Do not go red. Go and be it.*

And she said the scripture to them, there in the cold meeting-house, the one we all had at Branford from Mr. Pierson in the old Bible.

> *Wherefore, brethren, giue rather diligence to make your calling and election sure: for if ye doe these things, ye shall neuer fall.*
>
> *— 2 Peter 1:10 (Geneva Bible)*

Then she went home on her stick, and that same noon twelve of them came across the lot to my door, and the pottage was still hot, and I said what I always say. I could not help it. *Come in, saints.* And the young ones did not go red. They looked at me as though I had set them a task. The Lacey boy said, *Yes, Goodman Ambler. We are coming.*

IV. The Chimney

The same house lot · January 1667/8

Brethren, I would have stopped there and been content. But the Lord was not done, and this is the part I have never been able to say until now, and I am standing here to say it.

On the eighth night of the eleventh month, the chimney took fire. It was clay and wattle, as most of ours are yet, built in haste last summer, and it went up in the night and took the thatch, and by the time we had the children out the whole house was burning. You came running, all of you, with buckets from the Watering Place. The sixteen came first. They were young and they ran. They threw water till their coats froze on them, and it did no good, and we stood in the snow and watched it go. Everything I had built with these hands since we came over the water from Branford. The second house in six months.

I stood there, and Goodwife Bray came and stood by me, wrapped in a blanket somebody had put round her, and the light of my house was on her face. I said to her, *That is twice. The Lord takes everything I make.*

She said, *Hopestill. Did you think you made it?*

And she said the other scripture to me. Not loud. I do not think anybody heard it but me.

> *For we knowe that if our earthly house of this tabernacle be destroyed, we haue a building giuen of God, that is, an house not made with handes, but eternall in the heauens.*
>
> *— 2 Corinthians 5:1 (Geneva Bible)*

Brethren, I cannot tell you what happened then except that I saw it. I stood in the snow and watched the house go down, the ridgepole and the rafters and the door I had hung, everything I had made, everything Branford had made, everything New Haven made, the whole of our commonwealth with its book in a chest, all of it made with hands and all of it burning, the way it always would, the way it had to. And I saw that the thing I had been looking for in the saints for thirty years was not made. It was not made by them and not by me. It was not in my house and could not burn with it. It stood where it had always stood. It was the only thing on that lot that night that was not on fire.

And I was not afraid. That is the sum of what I have to tell. I had always been afraid. I had been afraid I was not one of them. And standing there with nothing, I did not care any more whether I was one of them. I only saw it, and was glad of it, and wanted nothing else.

The sixteen built me a house in nine days. You know that too. They cut the timber on the hill and carried it on their shoulders across the ice. They would not let me lift a stick. When it was done I stood at the new door and I said what I have always said, and I will say it as long as I live: *Come in, saints.*

That is my relation. I cannot say I am a saint. I can say I have seen the house not made with hands, and that I am not afraid. The brethren will judge.

V. The Vote

The clerk's note · the same day

THE BRETHREN BEING ASKED WHETHER THEY WERE SATISFIED, Sergeant Ruggles rose and said he had heard many relations and few so short, and that the judgment of charity had never been easier to give, and

HE FOR ONE WAS SATISFIED. THE REST HELD UP THEIR HANDS. Hopestill Ambler was received into full communion. When the vote was declared he said nothing, but sat down, and was seen to be laughing without noise.

Noted also: that this winter, since November, nine of the young men who ate at Ambler's table have come before the elders desiring to give their relations, of whom three have been heard and received, the Lacey boy among them. The others are in the way.

Noted also, at Goodwife Bray's request, though it is not the church's business: that when the exercise was over and the people went out, Ambler stood at his new door in the snow, the pottage being hot, and called to the whole congregation coming down the steps, members and half-way and the children and the two Dutchmen who had come over from Bergen to hear the preaching, *Come in, saints,* and a great many more than sixteen went in, and the door was left open, and nobody went red.

Background

The verse

> *Stop the stream valiantly, drive away the desires, O Brahmana! When you have understood the destruction of all that was made, you will understand that which was not made.*
>
> Dhammapada 383, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a brahmin named Pasādabahula, "Great Confidence," hears the Buddha and from then on feeds sixteen monks at his house, greeting every one of them as an arahat, a fully awakened one. The monks who are not yet awakened think he believes there are arahats among them; the ones who are think he cannot tell; all of them grow uncomfortable and stop coming. The brahmin, grieved, goes to the Buddha, who tells the monks that the greeting is only an expression of confidence, in which no fault can be found, that the brahmin's love for arahats is boundless, and that they should therefore cut off the stream of craving and settle for nothing less. Read the full commentary story.

Newark, New Jersey

Newark, 1666–1668

The New Haven Colony allowed only church members to hold civic rights. When the royal charter of 1662 folded it into Connecticut, which had no such rule, and as the churches debated the Half-Way Covenant of 1662, which let the children of baptized but unconverted parents be baptized in turn, the minister of Branford, Abraham Pierson, who disapproved of the covenant, led his people away. With settlers from Milford under Robert Treat, they founded Newark on the Passaic, carrying Branford's church records with them. The Branford company arrived in 1667, the land was bought from the Hackensack that July for a list of goods that included guns, kettles, coats and ten pairs of breeches, and in the new town no one was to enjoy full citizenship, vote or hold office unless a member of a Congregational church (Newark Public Library).

Puritan churches admitted full members by a "relation," a spoken account of the candidate's experience of saving grace, which the church weighed by what it called the judgment of charity, since only God could see the heart. The Geneva Bible, the Bible of the Puritan migration, is quoted from the 1599 edition (text). Hopestill Ambler, Goodwife Bray, Sergeant Ruggles, the Lacey boy and the fire are invented.

After the story of the brahmin Pasādabahula from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 383). The original. Scripture from the Geneva Bible (1599). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.2

Dit and Dah

> *Passion is overcome only by him who has won through stillness of spirit the perfect vision.*
> *— Śāntideva, The Path of Light, tr. L. D. Barnett*

Di ké dak gi thö pa, at the Garden.

I. Two Things

Camp Hale, Colorado · winter 1962–63

The Americans called the place the Ranch, and the Tibetans called it Dumra, the Garden. It was a fenced corner of an old Army camp at nine thousand two hundred feet, a few Quonset huts and four classrooms under the snow, with signs on the road that said *explosive ordnance* to keep the elk hunters out. The instructors went by first names only. Lyle taught code.

He was thirty-eight, from Hastings, Nebraska, a Navy radioman in one war and an instructor at a Navy school after it, and his wife believed he was testing cold-weather equipment for the Army. He had Classroom Three, thirty men who had come in October. They had been flown in at night with the windows covered, and nobody had told them what country they were in. Most were Khampas, from the east of Tibet, horsemen and traders and a good many former monks, and none of them had ever seen a telegraph key. They had American names, because the Americans could not manage the others. In five months Lyle had to bring every one of them to twelve words a minute, sending and receiving, in five-letter groups off a one-time pad, on a set that ran from a hand-cranked generator. After that they would go home and be the only voice coming out of their country.

The first morning he held up two fingers.

Two things, he said. *That's all there is. A short one and a long one. Dit, and dah. Everything you will ever send, the whole alphabet and every number, is put together out of those two. A man who has the two of them in his hand can say anything.*

The interpreter put it into Tibetan. He was a young man named Jampa who had been to a mission school in Kalimpong, and the Americans called him Jim. He stood beside the instructor's desk all day, in every class, and translated standing. Lyle never saw him use a chair.

The men liked the two things. They said the word to one another, *nyi, nyi,* and held up two fingers at Lyle when they passed him on the path to the mess hall. In the evenings, after the practice hour, he would go by their hut and see a dozen of them gathered at one bunk, and hear it again. *Nyi.* The two. He was pleased. He thought they were drilling.

The bunk belonged to the man the Americans had named Walt. He was forty-one, the oldest in the class by ten years, and the others did not use that name. They called him Gen-la, which Jim said meant teacher. He had been the chant master of the great monastery at Lithang until 1956, the year of the siege, when the Chinese planes came over it. He had gone to a lama then and given back his vows in the proper form, and after that he picked up a rifle. He had the slowest fist in Classroom Three and the best ear. He could copy a message through any noise Lyle put on the line, because, Jim said, he had spent twenty-five years listening for one wrong voice in a hall full of them.

II. The Question

March 1963

By February Lyle knew the class was good. Jim knew something else about it, and it was Jim who told him, in his careful school English, on the path one night.

These ones have stopped asking when they will go, Jim said. *The other rooms ask every day. In October these ones quarrelled at volleyball, and Hank and*

Dale did not speak for a week. Now look at them. I think they are very near something. It only needs a push.

Lyle said twelve words a minute was the only thing they needed to be near. Jim agreed that this was so.

The last Saturday of the course, the sending test was over and all thirty had passed it. Lyle stayed behind after supper to box up the practice keys. The men came into Classroom Three anyway and sat down at their desks, all thirty, with Walt in the second row where he always sat. The stove ticked. Nobody had called a class.

Jim came in last. He walked to the front, to his place by the desk, and he did not sit. He put his hands together and spoke to the second row in Tibetan. He spoke slowly and formally, and Lyle caught the one word he knew.

What did you ask him?

I said, Gen-la, people are always speaking of the two. What are the two?

You know what the two are. Dit and dah.

Jim did not answer that. He was waiting, and so were the thirty.

Walt said two words. Then he said a little more, perhaps a dozen words, in his ordinary voice. Then he straightened his back and chanted four lines, low, from the chest, and it was the first time Lyle had heard what that voice had been trained for. The windows hummed with it.

He says the two are staying and seeing, Jim said quietly. *The mind stays where it is put. Then it sees what is there. He says when a man has gone all the way across in both of these, every knot he has comes undone. The rest is from a book the monks have by heart. There is an English one. A man in London made it, and the fathers had it at my school.*

Lyle found the English one eleven years later, by mail, through the public library in Hastings. This is how the man in London had it.

> *Passion is overcome only by him who has won through stillness of spirit the perfect vision. Knowing this, I must first seek for stillness; it comes through the contentment that is regardless of the world.*
>
> — Śāntideva, The Path of Light, ch. VIII, tr. L. D. Barnett (1909)

Nothing happened in Classroom Three that Lyle could have put in a report. The men sat. The stove ticked. After a time one of them laughed, softly, the way a man laughs who has been looking for his hat and finds it on his head, and then Walt said something short, and they all got up and went to the mess hall. It was Saturday, when the cooks let them have the kitchen for dumplings.

It is finished for them, Jim said, on the path.

The course?

No.

In the camps in Mustang afterward, and in the settlements in Nepal and India after that, the men of Classroom Three were known. It was said of them that all thirty had crossed over on one night at the Garden, and that Gen-la had held the answer since October and was only waiting for somebody to ask. Nobody at the Ranch wrote it down. There was no form for it.

III. Loose Wrist

Camp Hale, 1963 · Hastings, Nebraska, 1974

MONDAY MORNING WAS THE RECEIVING TEST, AND AFTER IT Lyle ran the class through one more hour of sending, for his own satisfaction. He had taught code for sixteen years. He knew the sound of a frightened hand, which clips the dits and leans on the dahs, and the sound of a hand that wants to be finished. He walked the rows with his eyes shut. He heard thirty keys that morning and there was no hurry in any of them and no drag, and when he opened his eyes every wrist in the room was lying loose on the desk as if it belonged to nobody.

They left that week, at night, in a bus with the windows painted over. There was no more jumping by then. They were flown back across the Pacific and went in on foot, some over the passes into Tibet and most up to Mustang. Lyle was not told where any of them went, and over the years he learned the ends of only five. Two were killed inside Tibet before the summer was out. One did nineteen years in a Chinese prison and came out of it, a visitor said, the calmest man in Lhasa. One kept a tea stall in

Pokhara. It was said that Gen-la carried the radio for his group and never the rifle, and that he sent for six years from a ridge above the Kali Gandaki, slowly, and was never once asked to repeat.

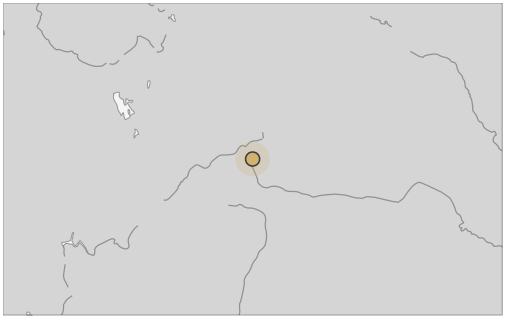
Lyle left the government in 1971 and went home to Hastings. The book came in a brown mailer from the state library in Lincoln, a thin volume with a library plate from 1911, and he read the page at his kitchen table three times. He still had the practice key from the second row. He screwed it to the edge of the table that night and sent the sentence through once, start to finish, with a loose wrist.

Background

The verse

> *If the Brahmana has reached the other shore in both laws (in restraint and contemplation), all bonds vanish from him who has obtained knowledge.*
>
> Dhammapada 384, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is a single paragraph. Thirty monks from a distant country come to see the Buddha and sit down. The elder Sāriputta sees that they are ready for the last step, goes to the Buddha and, without sitting down, asks a beginner's question on their behalf: people are always speaking of "the two states"; what are they? The Buddha answers that they are calm and insight (*samatha* and *vipassanā*; in Tibetan, *zhiné* and *lhakthong*), and speaks the verse. At the end of it all thirty are arahats. Müller, following another reading, took the two for restraint and contemplation. Read the full commentary story.



Camp Hale, Colorado

Camp Hale, 1958–1964

Camp Hale, in a high valley north of Leadville, was built in 1942 to train the ski troops of the 10th Mountain Division. From 1958 to 1964 the Central Intelligence Agency used a fenced corner of it to train some 250 to 300 Tibetan resistance fighters, in four contingents, the last of which arrived in October 1962. The program was secret; the cover story was atomic testing. The trainees, among them monks who had given back their vows to fight, called the camp Dumra, the Garden. Instructors went by first names and gave the Tibetans American ones, young English-speaking Tibetans interpreted, and by the instructors' own account the longest part of the course was Morse code and radio procedure. On Saturday nights the trainees took over the kitchen. Lyle, Jampa, Gen-la and Classroom Three are invented, as are the fates given for them.

The earlier teams were parachuted into Tibet, and most of those men were killed or captured. After overflights stopped in 1960, graduates were sent overland or to the guerrilla base in Mustang, in Nepal, which held out until 1974. In 2010 a plaque was placed at Camp Hale, and in 2022 the valley became part of a national monument. The great monastery at Lithang, in Kham, was besieged in 1956 with bomber aircraft overhead; Tibetan accounts say it was bombed. The lines Gen-la chants are from the eighth chapter of Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra*, which Tibetan monks commonly learn by heart; the English is L. D. Barnett's abridged version of 1909.

After the story of a company of bhikkhus from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 384). The original. Scripture from Śāntideva, *The Path of Light*, tr. L. D. Barnett (1909). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.3

Neither Bank

Unto Allah belong the East and the West, and whithersoever ye turn, there is Allah's Countenance.
— Qur'an 2:115

This is how the old ones carried it, on the Stono.

I. The Log

A landing on the Stono River, St. Paul's Parish, Carolina · March 1719

The Englishman who owned the landing had him in the plantation book as Boatswain, one Negro man, old, a canoe maker. His name was Lamin. He had been a boy on the Gambia, where a teacher made him write the Book on a wooden board in ink of pot-black, and wash the board, and write it again, until what had been on the board was in him where no water could get at it. He was taken at about twenty. That was forty years gone, with Barbados in between, and he still had most of it.

At the landing he made canoes. A cypress came down in the back swamp, oxen dragged it to the bank, and Lamin did the rest with fire and an adze. He laid coals along the top of the log and let them eat down a hand's depth, scraped out the char, and laid coals again. It took most of a month to get the inside of a tree out of it. When the walls were two fingers thick he filled the hull with water and dropped hot stones in and wedged the sides apart with sticks, a little wider each day. Then it was a boat. It went into the book, and it carried tar barrels and rice down to Charles Town on the tide.

He liked to say there was no carpentry in it. *I don't make anything. I take out what isn't canoe.*

Five times a day he went down to the river and washed his hands and mouth and face, his arms, his head and feet, and stood and bowed and knelt on a deerskin with his face up the creek toward where the sun rose. The overseer had long since decided there was no harm in it, since the canoes got made.

In those years there was a thing said in every quarter between the Santee and the Savannah, mostly at night and mostly low. People called it the far shore. Somewhere to the south, past more rivers than anyone had counted, the Spaniard had a stone fort and a town, and the Spanish king had sent word, before most of them were born, that any of the English king's slaves who reached it would be free. They poured water on your head there and gave you a saint's name. Some had gone and had not been brought back. The Yamasee, who had burned the next parish south four years before, lived under the Spaniard's wall now, and it was said there were black men among them who carried guns.

Nobody who meant to go asked Lamin where it was. They knew where it was. It was south. They asked him about the water: which creeks went through behind the islands and which ended in marsh, what the tide did at the cuts, how many could sit in a canoe of such a length and still show a hand's breadth of side. He told them. Then, in the dark of some moon, a canoe that had never been in any book would be gone from a place back in the swamp where he had been burning it out by night, and he would begin another.

He had sent off four that way. He was in none of them.

II. The Asker

Dusk

The man came along the bank at the hour when Lamin had finished the sunset prayer and was rolling up the skin. He wore an osnaburg shirt torn at the shoulder, and he was mud to the thigh, and he said he had run from a place up Goose Creek nine days back and had eaten nothing in three.

Lamin gave him what was in the pot, hominy and a piece of mullet. The man ate some of it. He sat on the cypress chips with his back to the new hull on its blocks, and he looked at the quarter: the six houses, the smoke, the path that went back toward the swamp.

Father, he said, *everywhere I go they are talking about the far shore. The far shore, the far shore. What is it they mean? Where does a man find this far shore?*

Lamin knew him then. It is told two ways how he knew.

The plain way is that a man nine days in the marsh does not leave fish in the bowl, and he looks at a canoe before he looks at anything else on a landing, and this one had not looked at the canoe once. He was counting houses. There were men in the parish who paid for that kind of counting.

The other way it is told, the dogs had not barked when he came, and the tide mud where he had walked held no track, and Lamin called him by a name out of the Book.

Whisperer, he said. *What have you to do with the far shore?*

The man smiled. *The same as anyone. I want to get there.*

You want to know where it is so you can stand in front of it. That is another thing. Lamin put the rolled skin under his arm. *Nobody comes to that bank carrying what you carry. The ones who get there have put it down first.*

I carry nothing, old man. Look at me.

You carry the count of these houses and what you mean to get for it. A man loaded like that sinks the boat at the landing.

Then he said something in the language he prayed in, the way a man says what he has had by heart since before his beard came. The people who told this afterward did not have those words. They had what he said next, in the speech of the landing, and those who know the Book say it lies close.

> *Unto Allah belong the East and the West, and whithersoever ye turn, there is Allah's Countenance. Lo! Allah is All-Embracing, All-Knowing.*
>
> *— Qur'an 2:115*
>
> *Lo! verily the friends of Allah are (those) on whom fear (cometh) not, nor do they grieve?*
>
> *— Qur'an 10:62*

Forty years I have been on this water, Lamin said. *One bank behind me and one in front, and turn the boat and it is the other way about. I never found the bank that was more His than the other one. A man who knows that, you cannot frighten him. Where would you drive him? And you cannot tie him. What would you tie him to? He is across already, wherever you find him sitting. That is all the far shore I have to tell. Take it to whoever is paying you.*

The man stood up. He looked once more at the swamp path, and then he looked at Lamin for some time, and it is said his face then was not the hungry face he had come with, nor any one face. He went back up the bank the way he had come. The dogs let him go.

III. The Ebb

The same night

WHAT THE ASKER HAD NOT COUNTED LAY IN THE CANE BEHIND the chip pile, flat on the ground, where it had been lying since before he came. There were eight grown people and a child, from three plantations, waiting for the dark of the moon and the ebb at midnight. A woman called Phibba had come from across the river with her girl of four. There were two brothers the English had named for Angola, and a cattle hunter from the cowpen at the head of the creek, and the rest. They had heard every word.

Some of them had been sick with fear since sundown. They were afraid of the scout boats and of the open water at the sounds. They were afraid of the Spaniard and his water and his saints, and afraid most of all that the place was only a thing people said. One of the brothers had already whispered that he would go back before he was missed. All of

them had carried the far shore in their minds as a bank so distant that the fear of the miles between had grown heavier than the thing they were leaving.

Phibba told it years afterward in Augustine, where she was called by another name and sold oranges at the plaza gate. She said that between one breath and the next the river stopped having a wrong side. She had no better way to say it. The fear was there and then she looked for it and it had nothing to stand on.

Nobody went back. When the dogs were quiet they went down the swamp path and found the canoe, which still smelled of its burning, and carried it to the creek and got in as he had told them, the heavy men at the ends and the child in the middle. Lamin did not push them off. He stood on the bank and the ebb took them.

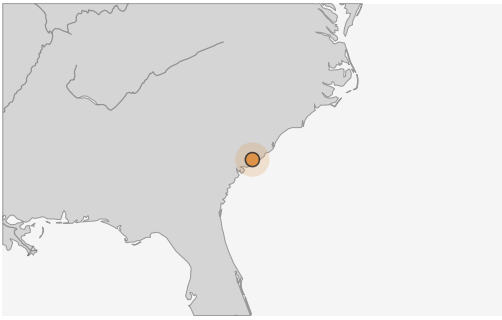
He watched until the hull was only a darker piece of the dark, out in the stream, and from where he stood he could not have said which bank it was nearer to. Then he went back up through the cane to where the next cypress lay. It had been down since autumn and the bark was still on it. He felt along the top of it with his palm for the place where the coals would go.

Background

The verse

> *He for whom there is neither this nor that shore, nor both, him, the fearless and unshackled, I call indeed a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 385, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary story is four sentences long. Māra, the tempter, puts on a disguise, comes to the Buddha at Jetavana and asks what this "far shore" is that people keep speaking of. The Buddha knows him at once and says, "Wicked One, what have you to do with the far shore? That may be gained only by those who have freed themselves from the passions." He then speaks the verse, and many of those listening enter the stream. Read the full commentary story, or about Māra.



Stono River, South Carolina

The Carolina lowcountry, 1719

By 1708 enslaved Africans and their descendants were the majority of South Carolina's people. They raised cattle in open-range cowpens, burned tar and pitch, grew rice, and built and crewed the dugout cypress canoes that carried all of it to Charles Town; the College of Charleston's Lowcountry Digital History Initiative describes that early world. Many came from Senegambia, where Islam was old and boys learned the Qur'an by writing it on washable boards. Lamin, the landing and everyone on it are invented. The Yamasee War of 1715 was real: it left St. Bartholomew's Parish, the next one south of the Stono country, plundered and burned, and afterward most of the Yamasee withdrew to Spanish Florida.

The "far shore" was real too. In October 1687 eight men, two women and a small child reached St. Augustine from Carolina by boat, and the governor refused to give them back. In 1693 the Spanish crown ordered liberty for all such fugitives, "the men as well as the women," on condition of Catholic baptism. For the next seventy years people went south by canoe through the creeks behind the Sea Islands, as the National Park Service recounts in its history of Africans in St. Augustine. One of them, a Mandinga man baptized Francisco Menéndez, became captain of the free Black militia and, in 1738, of Fort Mose, the first legally sanctioned free Black town in what is now the United States. Freedom there was conditional and often slow in coming. People went anyway.

After the story of Māra from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 385). The original. Scripture from *The Meaning of the Glorious Koran*, tr. Marmaduke Pickthall (1930). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.4

The Widow's Priests

Be of the disciples of Aharon; loving peace, and pursuing peace.
— Pirqe Aboth i. 13

Assim mo contaram, on Mill Street.

I. The Basin

Mill Street, New York · the weeks of the Omer, 1706

Dona Branca Lopes lived in one room over a cooper's shed at the low end of Mill Street, three doors from the house where the nation rented an upper floor for its synagogue. She was past seventy. She had been born at Trancoso in Portugal, in a house where her mother lit the Friday lamp inside a clay jar so that no light showed at the shutters. In that town there was no synagogue, no scroll, no reader and no priest, and a neighbor who saw clean linen on a Friday could send a family to the Holy Office.

She had come out by Bayonne and Amsterdam. A nephew in the Curaçao trade brought her to New York, and the yellow fever of 1702 took him and left her. Now she taught the children of the nation their letters, for whatever the parents sent up the stair: a loaf, a string of candle ends, half a cord of wood in the fall.

There were about a hundred Jews in the town that year, most of them Portuguese like herself, and a few Germans the Portuguese called *tudescos*. Her pupils were seven. The eldest was a girl of eleven, Sarah Nunes. The youngest was Leyb, five years old, whose father Hirsch was a tudesco from Fürth and made tallow candles in a shed behind the slip.

Inside her door, on a stool, stood a pewter basin and a cup. A child coming in poured water three times over each hand and dried them on

the cloth. Then the child sat down on the bench and kept still. Then, when she nodded, the child said yesterday's portion through without the book, three letters for the small ones and a line of the prayers for the big ones. When all seven had done it she looked along the bench and said the same thing every day.

Bom. Now my priests may begin.

Meus cohanim, she called them. One at a time it was *meu cohen,* the girls the same as the boys. She called nobody that who had not washed and sat and said the portion. There was a fourth rule under the three. If a child came up the stair with a quarrel still in him, having hit a brother or called the candlemaker's boy a name in the street, she seemed to know it by the way he held the cup, and she sent him back down.

A priest goes up with clean hands. Go and get yours clean. The water is only to remind you.

II. The Cohen

The thirty-third day

Senhor Daniel Cohen Faro shipped flour and barrel staves to Curaçao and brought back cocoa. He had a brick house on Dock Street and a pew, such as it was, nearest the ark. He was a Cohen. His father had been one and his father's father, and the two spread hands were cut on his grandfather's stone at Ouderkerk. On the festivals he took off his shoes and went up before the ark with his prayer shawl over his head and blessed the congregation, and when a firstborn son was redeemed the five pieces of silver were laid in his palm. He was not a proud man about most things. About this he was careful, which he held to be different.

He passed under her window every day on his way to the waterside, and every day he heard it. *Now my priests may begin.* One afternoon he climbed the stair and looked in at the door. He saw a bench of children. One was a girl, and one was the tudesco's boy, whose feet did not reach the floor.

He thought about it for a week, because he was a fair man. A widow may call children what she likes. But she was learned in her way, and the nation deferred to her on the fast days and on how a thing had been done in the old country. In six years she had never called him anything but Senhor Daniel. If the word was going so freely about Mill Street, it seemed to him it ought to stop first at the one man in the street it belonged to.

So he went up after the children had gone. She was wiping out the basin.

Dona Branca. You call these children cohanim.

I do.

I am a Cohen. From my father, and from his, back to Aaron. To you I am Senhor Daniel.

It is a good name.

I am not asking you for honors. I am asking what you mean by the word, when you give it to a candlemaker's son and keep it from me.

She set the basin on the stool.

In my mother's house we had no Cohen. Nobody in Trancoso knew anymore what he was. The books that said so were burned before my grandmother was born. So my mother said, whoever in this house has washed, and has done today what was his to do, and has no quarrel with anyone under the roof, and can sit down quiet, that one is our priest tonight, and he says the blessing. Some nights it was my brother. Some nights it was the girl who carried the water. Some nights it was nobody, and we ate without.

That was need. Here we have the thing itself.

Here we have your father's name, senhor. I was fifty years in a country that called people by their fathers and their grandfathers, to the fourth generation, and looked in the registers to see whose blood was clean. I do not call anyone that way. I never learned how.

She asked him what the men had read in the synagogue on the first Sabbath afternoon after the Passover. He knew it as well as she did. She said it anyway, in the Spanish of the Amsterdam prayer book, and waited after it as she waited after a child's portion.

> *Hillel said, Be of the disciples of Aharon; loving peace, and pursuing peace; loving mankind, and bringing them nigh to the Thorah.*
>
> *— Pirqe Aboth i. 13*

He does not say sons, she said. *Hillel could count. He knew Aaron had sons. He says disciples. So wash, senhor. Do what is yours to do. Go and find whoever it is you are not speaking to, and run after peace with him until you catch it. Then come and sit down, and I will know what to call you.*

He had not told her about the candlemaker. Among a hundred Jews nobody needed to be told. At Purim he had bought ship's candles of Hirsch and found the cask a pound short, by his own steelyard, and had held back forty shillings of the price. Hirsch had called him a thief in two languages on the open street. They had not spoken since. Hirsch was a Levite, and it is the Levite who pours the water over the Cohen's hands before he goes up to bless. At Passover Hirsch had stood in his place with his arms folded, and a firstborn had poured instead, and the whole room had watched it.

III. The Cup

The eve of the Feast of Weeks, and the morning

He counted the days with the rest of them each night after the evening prayer, the thirty-fourth, the fortieth, the forty-eighth. He did nothing. A man can turn a sentence over for two weeks and still call it thinking.

On the forty-ninth day, before sunset, he walked down to the shed behind the slip. It stank of tallow. The boy Leyb was on the floor sorting wicks by length. Daniel put forty shillings on the bench in Spanish silver and said, in Portuguese, that he had weighed that cask in a wet week, and that a wet week adds nothing to tallow but does things to a man's temper. Hirsch looked at the money for some time. He had been expecting the constable. He answered in a Portuguese that was mostly German. He said his beam scale had been his father's and might be a little kind to the seller. Then he took down a pound of candles, weighed it where Daniel

could see the pointer, and put it on top of the money. Neither of them touched either pile. After a while the boy got up off the floor and took his father's hand and looked at the Cohen's shoes.

In the morning the upper room on Mill Street was hung with green boughs from the Bowery road, and the reader chanted the portion about the mountain, where every water carrier in Israel is told that the whole people shall be priests. When the time came Daniel Cohen Faro took off his shoes and went to the back of the room. Hirsch the candlemaker was already standing there with the cup. He poured three times over each hand, slowly, the way a child does who has been taught it lately. Daniel stood and looked at his own two hands with the water running off them, and he was a moment late going up.

• • •

The day after the festival he climbed the widow's stair at the children's hour. He had no portion to say, and said so. He poured the water for himself at the stool and dried his hands on the cloth and sat down at the end of the bench beside Leyb, with his knees higher than the bench. He kept still.

Dona Branca looked along the row, the seven and the one, and nodded. *Bom,* she said. *Now my priests may begin.*

She opened the book to the aleph.

Background

The verse

> *He who is thoughtful, blameless, settled, dutiful, without passions, and who has attained the highest end, him I call indeed a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 386, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary a man who is a Brahmin by birth and lineage notices that the Buddha calls his own disciples Brahmins, and reasons that the title ought to be given to him as well. He goes and asks. The Buddha answers that he calls no one a Brahmin for birth or lineage, only the one who has reached the goal, and speaks the verse;

the Brahmin is established in the first fruit of the path. Read the full commentary story. The nearest Jewish counterpart to a Brahmin by birth is the Kohen, the hereditary priest descended from Aaron, and Hillel's saying in Pirkei Avot makes the same turn from sons to disciples. It is quoted from Charles Taylor's *Sayings of the Jewish Fathers* (1897), where it is numbered i. 13; most editions count it 1:12. The tractate is traditionally read a chapter a week on the Sabbaths between Passover and Shavuot, the weeks of the counting of the Omer.

New York, New York

Mill Street, 1706

New York's Jews, about a hundred people at the turn of the eighteenth century, worshipped in rented rooms, first on Beaver Street and by 1700 on Mill Street, now South William Street. They did not build a synagogue of their own until 1730. The congregation became Shearith Israel, the oldest in the United States. Most of its early families were Portuguese and Spanish Jews, many only a generation or two out of the Iberian peninsula, with a growing number of Ashkenazim, and the Gotham Center describes the friction and the shared life between the two. Dona Branca, Daniel Cohen Faro, Hirsch and the children are invented.

Branca's childhood is the world of crypto-Judaism. After the forced conversions of the 1490s, families in Portugal kept what they could of Jewish practice in secret for two centuries, without books or clergy, and it was very often the women who carried it. Around them Iberian society sorted people by the statutes of *limpieza de sangre*, purity of blood, which traced a "New Christian" ancestor back through the generations. In the priestly blessing, which Spanish and Portuguese congregations perform on the festivals, the Kohanim remove their shoes and the Levites wash their hands, and a Kohen who is on bad terms with the congregation is not supposed to go up.

After the story of a certain Brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 386). The original. Pirkei Avot from *Sayings of the Jewish Fathers*, tr. Charles Taylor (1897). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.5

Light Enough

Lighten our darkness, we beseech thee, O Lord.
— The Book of Common Prayer, Evening Prayer

As I heard it reported, at James Fort.

I. The Winter

James Fort, Virginia · 1609–10

Five hundred English were in the fort when the leaves came down, and sixty in May. The ground was Paspahegh ground and nobody had asked the Paspahegh for it. By November the great king Powhatan's men had shut the English up inside their own palisade, and whoever went out past the blockhouse after roots, or after a shot at a deer, did not come in again. They ate the horses. They ate the dogs and the cats and then the rats, and the starch meant for ruffs, boiled to a paste, and the leather of their shoes. They ate worse than that, and it is set down in other places. They were afraid of the woods, so for firewood they pulled down the houses of the dead, and then the gates, and then the palisade itself, a post at a time.

There was no minister. Master Hunt was two years in the ground and the man sent to follow him was cast away on the Bermudas and thought drowned. So the widow Alse Reeve did what there was to do. She had come in the August ships with a husband, a joiner, who died of the flux before the first frost. She was fifty or near it, a Wiltshire woman who could read, and she owned a Prayer Book that had lost its back board. When word came that someone in a cabin would not see morning she went there and sat down on the floor. At dark she said the evening collects, as if a bell had rung for them. Then she stayed. People died slowly

that winter and mostly at night, and she did not like any of them to do it alone.

A ship's boy off the *Unity* named Kit Dawe, twelve years old, fastened himself to her the way a boy will. He drew her water from the well in the fort and came to find her at whatever house she was in. The rest of this is from Kit.

He held to it all his life that in those cabins there was no fire, because the only wood left was the wall that kept the wind out, and no candle, and no rush or pine splinter, and that he never once had to feel his way to her. In any room where she sat there was light enough to see a dying man's face by. It was not much. It was about what a horn lantern gives with the shutter half across. The men of the night watch knew it, and would say to each other that the widow was at Cope's tonight, or at the cooper's, having seen it under a door. Nobody spoke of it to her. It was of use, and that winter no one had the strength to wonder at a thing that was of use.

II. Midsummer Day

Sunday, 24 June 1610

Then in three weeks everything was altered. Sir Thomas Gates came up the river in two pinnaces built of Bermuda cedar, with near seven score castaways who had lived ten months on wild hogs and turtles and sea birds and were as fat and brown as farmers. They looked at the sixty and the sixty looked at them. Gates gave the place up and put everyone aboard, and they were a day down the river when my Lord De La Warr's longboat met them, with three ships behind it and a year's victual, and turned them round.

His lordship had the fort scoured and the church mended. There were two bells again, and prayers at ten and at four, and on a Sunday he went to the sermon with the Council and the captains and fifty halberdiers in red cloaks, and sat in the quire in a chair of green velvet.

Midsummer Day fell on his third Sunday. At evening, before the watch was set, he walked the round of the new bulwarks with his guard behind

him. The widow was sitting on the well curb picking over ship's pease in her apron, and Kit sat by her, because that was where he sat.

He was a boy who looked at things. He looked up the river, where the sun was going down red into the trees of the far bank and the whole breadth of the James had taken fire from it. He looked the other way, over the marsh, where the moon, a day or two short of the full, had got up white before the sun was done. He looked at my lord coming along the palisade in the midst of his red cloaks, with the last of the sun on fifty halberd heads and on the gilt of his sword hangers. He looked at the church door. One of the Bermuda men knelt there still, an hour after the bell. He was a shipwright called Nicholas who had worked on the two pinnaces, island cedar and the gear of a wreck. His eyes were shut and his face and forearms were burnt the color of a new penny, and he was so easy on his knees in the dust that the red cloaks parted and went round him as water goes round a post.

And he looked at the widow. She was as grey as the rest of the sixty. Her hair had come out in the hungry months and she wore the gown she had landed in. His eyes stayed on her, because they were at rest there.

Mother Reeve, he said. *I have looked at the sun and the moon, and at my lord, and at that Bermuda man, and they are all very fine. But I had rather look at you. There is more light on you than on any of them. There was all winter.*

She went on with the pease.

The sun has the day, Kit. The moon has the night. My lord shines when he is dressed and has his guard about him, and God knows we had need of him. That man at the door shines while he is on his knees, and I hope he may be let stay there. Each has its hour.

And yours?

It was never mine. There was no minister, so I asked. The same words every night. They were all I knew to ask.

> *Lighten our darkness, we beseech thee, O Lord; and by thy great mercy defend us from all perils and dangers of this night; for the love of thy only Son, our Saviour Jesus Christ. Amen.*
>
> *— The Book of Common Prayer, the Third Collect at Evening Prayer*

And it was not kept back, she said. *That is all the difference. What is given that way keeps no hours. It does not go in when the sun comes out, and it does not want dressing.* She tipped the bad pease out of her palm onto the ground. *Anyone may ask. Only you must be sitting there in the dark to do it, and most would sooner be abed.*

III. The Flux

July

THE SUMMER SICKNESS CAME UP WITH THE HEAT, AS IT DOES on that river, and it went hardest with the new-come. The widow went back to sitting on floors. There were ministers now, and candles out of the store for the dying, and she said the collect all the same.

On a night when she was at the far end of the fort, the shipwright Nicholas lay in his cabin with the flux and nobody by him. He told it afterward. He woke in the black of the night wanting water, and a cup was put to his mouth. When he had drunk he saw who held it. It was the ship's boy who went about after the widow, sitting on the floor with his back to the bed frame, his lips moving over something he had by rote. The candle allowed for the cabin had burned out before midnight. Nicholas could see the boy's face well enough, and the cup, and the grain of the wall post behind him.

He was a man who had been looked at all his life for his own stillness, and he knew what he was seeing. He said nothing and shut his eyes.

In the morning the boy was asleep where he sat, with the cup in his lap, and the light in the room was the ordinary kind, coming in under the door.

Background

The verse

> *The sun is bright by day, the moon shines by night, the warrior is bright in his armour, the Brahmana is bright in his meditation; but Buddha, the Awakened, is bright with splendour day and night.*
>
> Dhammapada 387, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary it is the evening of the great festival that closes the rains. King Pasenadi comes to the monastery in all his ornaments, the elder Kāḷudāyī sits at the edge of the assembly deep in meditation, his body the color of gold, and the sun is setting as the moon rises. The Buddha's attendant Ānanda looks at each radiance in turn and tells his teacher that his alone satisfies. The Buddha answers that the sun shines by day, the moon by night, the king when he is adorned and the saint when he is absorbed, but that Buddhas shine by night and by day alike. Read the full commentary story, or about Ānanda.

Jamestown, Virginia

Jamestown, 1610

About five hundred colonists were at Jamestown in the autumn of 1609, and about sixty were alive the next spring. The winter is remembered as the Starving Time. The Powhatan chiefdom, on whose land the fort stood, kept the English penned inside it; they ate horses, dogs, rats and laundry starch, burned their own houses for firewood, and in at least one case ate the dead. On May 23, 1610, the survivors of the wrecked flagship *Sea Venture* arrived from Bermuda in two small ships they had built there. On June 7 the colony was abandoned, and within days it was turned back in the river by the arrival of Lord De La Warr with three ships. Alse Reeve, Kit Dawe and the shipwright Nicholas are invented.

The governor's state is from William Strachey's letter known as the *True Reportory*: the repaired church with its two bells, prayers at ten and four, the fifty halberdiers in "fair red cloaks," the green velvet chair. Midsummer Day of 1610 did fall on a Sunday by the old calendar, with the moon close to full. The collect is the one the Prayer Book appoints for every evening of the year. What followed the relief was not gentle. That August De La Warr sent soldiers against the Paspahegh, whose town was burned and whose people, the children of their chief among them, were killed; by the next year the Paspahegh no longer appear in the record as a nation on their own ground.

After the story of the Elder Ānanda from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 387). The original. The collect from the Book of Common Prayer. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.6

Hatched at Home

That bird of self-love which was hatched at home, if it be not looked to, will eat out the life of all grace and goodness.
— Robert Cushman, sermon preached at Plymouth, 1621

Thus I heard it, at New Plymouth.

I. The Removals

New Plymouth · May 1638

By the spring of 1638 the town was going over the water. Every week a cart went up the shore toward Duxbury with a bedstead roped on it legs up and a kettle wedged between the legs, and every week a shallop went off from the landing toward Greens Harbor with somebody's chests to the gunwales. Nobody was leaving the colony. They were only leaving the town. Kine sold at twenty pound in the Bay that year, some at twenty-eight, and a man with kine had to have meadow, and the meadow was across the bay. The houses they left stood with the doors pegged, and grass came up in the dooryards, and the street that had lived close under the fort hill for seventeen years was, as the old planters said to one another, very thin.

The Widow Ware did not remove. She was sixty-eight. She had walked out of Nottinghamshire in 1608 with the others and lived fourteen years in Leiden, where she learned to sit with the sick, and had come over in the *Anne* in the summer of 1623 with her husband Thomas, a cooper, and two boys. Thomas died in the infectious fever of 1633, the year the great flies came up out of holes in the ground and made the woods ring. Both her sons had gone to Duxbury with their cattle and wanted her there. She

kept her house on the street and her garden and her four hens, and went to anyone who sent.

Rowland Fenn came in the last week of May leading two she-kids on a cord.

He was a Norfolk man of about fifty, long in the arm, with a beard he cut himself with shears. He had come out of the bishop's church at home when the new bishop at Norwich began putting the godly ministers out of their pulpits, and out of his brother's house over the same quarrel, and had joined the church at Boston in 1636 and come out of that too, in the winter they took the guns from the men who held with Mrs. Hutchinson. He would not go with them to the island in the spring. He came south instead into Plymouth's patent and hired a neck of rough ground beyond the Jones River that nobody wanted yet, and kept goats on it, and lived in a hut of his own building with no glass in the window. He did not come to meeting. He called himself a seeker, by which he meant that the true church had not been gathered anywhere on the earth since the apostles died, and he would know it when it was.

She-kids were going at thirty shillings that spring and often at forty, because every family that went over the water wanted a milch goat to carry them until their cows came in. Rowland got forty apiece at the landing from a Greens Harbor man, in silver, and counted it into his purse, and took it out and counted it again.

The shallop was loading. An old planter who had come in the first ship stood on the landing to see the family off, and when the wife began to cry he said what the old planters said at every removal. *Never mind it. We are but strangers and pilgrims, wherever we lie down.*

Rowland Fenn laughed out loud, and the old man turned and looked at him, and Rowland put his purse away and went up the street to the Widow Ware's.

• • •

He ate at her table whenever he came in. In February he had lain three days with an ague on the neck with nobody to milk, and somebody had told her, and she had walked out to him over the river ice and sat with

him and milked his goats and given him broth with a spoon. Since then he came to her door. He came, too, because she was the one person on the street who would let him talk.

Did you hear the old man at the landing?

I wasn't at the landing.

Strangers and pilgrims. They go over the bay for grass and call it a pilgrimage. He broke his bread into the pottage. *Your people tell everybody they came out. Separate, they say. Out of what? They came out of England in a body, with their elder and their pots and their quarrels, and sat down here in a body. Now they go out of Plymouth for cows.* He held up his hand and counted on it. *I came out of the bishop's church. I came out of my brother's house. I came out of Boston. I would not go to the island. I'll not come into yours. If any man in this patent has gone out, Goodwife, it's I.*

She cut him more bread.

You have five, she said.

Five what?

On your hand. Eat.

II. Platters and Dishes

The first of June

He came again on the first day of June with two more kids, because the Greens Harbor man's brother wanted a pair, and after he had sold them he sat at her table in the afternoon with the door open for the warmth and went on with it. He had been going on with it since Candlemas. She sat by the door mending a shift and let him.

Come out from among them, and separate yourselves, saith the Lord. It's the whole ground your people stand on. And I'm the only one in this patent that's done it.

She bit the thread.

The noise came before anything else. It came out of the north, low, a murmur like thunder a long way off over the woods, and they both looked toward the door to see the cloud, and there was no cloud. Then it was nearer and under them. The pewter on the shelf above the hearth began

to talk, platter against platter, and walked, and three of them went off the edge one after another and rang on the hearthstones. The pail by the door slopped. The whole house leaned and came back like a ship.

She was out of the door before he was off the bench. Outside the street was moving the way a blanket moves when somebody under it turns over. She took hold of the pales of her garden fence with both hands and held on and the pales held on to the ground. Rowland stood in the doorway gripping the post. Down the street the women were all out, each one holding to a post or a pale, and a chimney top at the far end let go its clay in a long slide, and a dog went past under the fences on its belly, and the hens flew up onto the woodpile, and then it eased, and then it stopped.

Nobody spoke for a while. Then everybody did.

Goodwife Atwood from next door came along the fence with her hand on her chest. *The chief men were all met in one house,* she said, *with the friends that are removing. It took them in the middle of their talk. Did you ever. As if the Lord would show us what He thinks of our shaking ourselves to pieces.*

Rowland let go of the post. His face was white above the beard, but he was smiling. *There, Goodwife,* he said to the widow. *There's the answer to your pilgrims. He shakes them for their cows.*

The Widow Ware went in and picked her platters up off the hearth. One had a dent in the rim where it had struck the firedog. She pressed at the dent with her thumb.

He shook my platters, she said, *and I am not removing. And He shook you, that has gone out of everything.*

He began to answer and she held up her hand with the platter in it.

Mr. Cushman stood up here the first winter, she said, *when the Fortune came, and preached to the ones that were left alive. I wasn't here. Thomas bought the little book in London the year after, with no name on it, and read it to me all the way over in the Anne, and there's nobody in this town didn't know whose it was. I'll say you the piece I have.*

She did not say it the way a minister says a thing. She said it the way she said what was in a broth, looking at the dent.

> *It is indeed a matter of some commendation for a man to remove himself out of a thronged place into a wide wilderness; to take in hand so long and dangerous a journey, to be an instrument to carry the Gospel and humanity among the brutish heathen; but there may be many goodly shews and glosses and yet a pad in the straw, men may make a great appearance of respect unto God, and yet but dissemble with him, having their own lusts carrying them: … let the shew be what it will, the substance is naught, and that bird of self-love which was hatched at home, if it be not looked to, will eat out the life of all grace and goodness: and though men have escaped the danger of the sea, and that cruel mortality, which swept away so many of our loving friends and brethren; yet except they purge out this self-love, a worse mischief is prepared for them …*
>
> *— Robert Cushman, The Sin and Danger of Self-Love, preached at Plymouth, 1621*

We were never called anything for the walking, she said. *A body that has walked out of Scrooby, and out of Amsterdam, and out of Leiden, and over the sea, is a body that has walked. Nobody is gone out for that. He is gone out when the thing is gone out of him.* She set the platter back on the shelf. *Come out from among them, and separate yourselves. You've said it to me at this table since Candlemas. You never say the rest of the verse.*

He knew the rest of the verse. Everybody did.

And touch none unclean thing, she said. *That's the half that's the going out.*

And what is my unclean thing, Goodwife? I've no cows. I've no glass in my window.

You counted your shillings twice on the landing, she said. *I heard about it from three people. And you count the places you've come out of on your fingers, the same way, twice, to anybody that will sit still for it. The bishop and your brother and Boston and the island and us. You carry it out of every house you go out of, like they carry their kettles to Duxbury. It came over in the ship with you. It's the one thing you never left.*

He got up off the bench so hard it went over, and went out into the garden.

III. The Second Noise

Half an hour after

He sat on her chopping block among the bean poles with his back to the house. He was going to go home. He would go home and not come in again, and that would be one more place, and he caught himself putting it on the hand with the others.

The second noise came then, out of the north the same way, but lower, and the ground went under him once like a horse shifting its feet, not so strong as the first. Up and down the street he heard the women cry out and run for their posts again. He did not take hold of anything. He sat on the block with his hands on his knees and let it come through him and go on south toward Manomet and the Cape, and he saw the thing.

He could never afterward say it better than that. He had been looking out from it all his life, the way a man looks out from a window and never sees the glass, and now for the space of the shaking it was outside him and he was looking at it. It was small. It was the size of a sparrow. It had come out of the bishop's church with him and out of his brother's door and off the ship at Boston and down the path to the neck, and it was fed, and loud, and it was not Rowland Fenn. It was only a thing he had been carrying. He had five places on his hand, and it had been with him at every one of them, and he had never once gone out of anything.

The shaking stopped. A hen came down off the woodpile. He found that he was laughing, and that his face was wet, and that it did not matter which.

• • •

When he came back in, the widow was sweeping up the clay that had come down the chimney. He did not say anything about it, and she did not ask. He went out again to Thomas Ware's old shop at the back, where the shaving horse still stood with the cobwebs on it, and found a riven lath and a hammer and five nails in a dish, and he came in and nailed the lath along the front of the shelf over the hearth a thumb's height above

the board. She handed him the platters one at a time and he stood them behind it. The dented one he put at the end where she could reach it.

The shaking may come again, he said. *They say there'll be more.*

It may, she said.

The small shakings did come, for near three weeks, a little one most days, and nobody in the town could get used to them. He walked home that evening over the Jones River with no kids on the cord and the purse in his coat, and did not count it.

• • •

The summers after that year were cold and wet, for several years together, and the Indian corn often did not ripen. In 1640 the price fell all at once, the way the old planters had feared, so that a cow that was worth twenty pound one month would fetch five the next, and a milch goat that had gone at three pound would not bring ten shillings. The removals went on anyway. Rowland Fenn kept his goats on the neck. He never did come to meeting, and nobody in Plymouth ever called him anything but the goat man. But he came into town every week with milk for whoever was sick, and when the Widow Ware lay dying in the winter of 1645, it was he that sat with her the last three nights and spooned the broth.

Her grandson had the house after. The lath was still on the shelf. When the ground moved again, in the winter of 1663, he heard the platters talk to each other in the dark, and lean, and stay where they were.

Background

The verse

> *Because a man is rid of evil, therefore he is called Brahmana; because he walks quietly, therefore he is called Samana; because he has sent away his own impurities, therefore he is called Pravragita (Pabbagita, a pilgrim).*
>
> Dhammapada 388, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a brahmin who had gone forth as an ascetic under some other teacher heard that the Buddha called his own monks *pabbajita*, "those who have gone

forth," and reasoned that the name ought to fit him too, since he had also left home. He went to the Buddha and said so. The Buddha answered that nobody is called gone forth for leaving a house; a person is called gone forth because the stains have gone forth out of him, and spoke the verse, which explains each holy name by a pun on what has been put away. The brahmin reached the first stage of awakening as he listened. Read the full commentary story, or about pabbajjā, the going forth.

New Plymouth, Plymouth Colony

Plymouth, 1638

The Separatists of Plymouth Colony had come out of the Church of England, out of Nottinghamshire to Amsterdam in 1608, then to Leiden, then over the sea in 1620. In the 1630s the great migration into Massachusetts Bay drove up the price of livestock, and William Bradford recorded kine selling at £20 to £28, a milch goat at £3 or £4, and female kids at 30 to 40 shillings. Planters who had stock went out to their outlying grants for meadow, the Duxbury people were dismissed to form their own church, and Bradford feared the scattering would "be the ruin of New England." In 1640 cattle prices collapsed: a cow that had been worth £20 fell to £5. Bradford's own account is in his history of Plimoth Plantation. Rowland Fenn's Boston is the town of the Antinomian Controversy, after which Anne Hutchinson's supporters were disarmed and many went to Aquidneck Island in 1638.

Bradford also describes the earthquake of about the first of June, 1638 (June 11 by the modern calendar): heard before it was felt, like distant thunder out of the north, shaking platters and dishes off the shelves while "the cheefe of this towne were mett together at one house" with friends who were removing, so that women outdoors had to catch hold of posts and pales, with a second, weaker shock about half an hour later. He noted that the summers for several years afterward were cold. The sermon the widow quotes was given at Plymouth in December 1621 by Robert Cushman, a layman and the colony's agent, during his month-long visit on the *Fortune*; it was printed in London in 1622 without his name. The text here follows the Boston reprint of 1846, *The Sin and Danger of Self-Love*.

After the story of a certain one gone forth from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 388). The original. Scripture from Robert Cushman's Plymouth sermon of 1621 (Boston, 1846) and, in passing, the Geneva Bible. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.7

Brickbats

Smite not the smiter to save thine own cheek.
— Adin Ballou, Christian Non-Resistance (1846)

This is how we tell it, in the smoking car of the 7:52.

I. The Wager

Glen Arden, Illinois · October 1886

There were eleven of us that year who rode in to the city every morning in the smoking car of the 7:52, and if you had asked any of us what we thought about we would have said the price of coal, or the Board of Trade, or our wives, or the anarchists. That was the year of the anarchists. Since May every paper in Chicago had been full of the bomb in the Haymarket and the seven policemen, and in August the jury gave seven of the eight men the rope, and the whole North Shore said it was about time. Gates, who sold coal and feed by the depot, said he would pull the trap himself and not charge the county. We laughed at that. We were not cruel men. We were the kind of men who live eighteen miles out on the North Western so that our children will have elms.

We talked about Elias Dunning too, the way you talk about the weather in another town.

Dunning kept books for a wholesale grocer on Lake Street and rode the coach behind us, because he did not smoke, and in nine years not one of us had ever seen him put out. You could step on his foot in the aisle. You could spill your coffee down him at the Wells Street lunch counter. Young Hollis from the Board of Trade had once, for a joke, taken his umbrella off the rack every morning for a week and left it on the platform, and every evening Dunning came back from the city, found it leaning by

the baggage room, said good evening to the agent, and carried it home. He went on Sunday afternoons to old Mr. Pryor's, the clock man on Spring Street, where five or six people sat in the parlor and read out of some books. People said the old man had grown up in a community down East where they shared everything and would not fight. We didn't know what to make of that. We liked Dunning, the way you like a well that never goes dry.

Royal Thayer came out from Peoria in the summer and bought the brick house on Ridge Avenue. He was a lawyer and a good one, a big pink easy man with a laugh you could hear through the partition into the coach, and before September he was the best company in the smoking car. He read the *Truth Seeker* on the train and had heard Colonel Ingersoll lecture eleven times, and he told us so, and he said the thing that made him angriest in the world was a Christian.

Not the religion, he said. *I can stand the religion. It's the face. Every Christian in this county went to church in May and came home and said hang them. Love your enemies, and pass the rope. Every one of them has a fist in his pocket. You show me one that hasn't.*

Somebody said Dunning.

We told him about the umbrella. We told him the coffee. Ober the insurance man said he would bet a box of Havanas that nothing on God's earth could make Elias Dunning raise his hand, and Thayer laughed his big laugh and took him, and we all forgot about it by Rogers Park.

II. The Platform

Monday, the 18th

It was a fog morning off the lake, the kind where the engine comes up the track as a sound before it is a thing. We were standing in a bunch at the smoking-car end of the platform with our papers. Dunning was down by the coach steps with his umbrella and his dinner in a newspaper, reading the timetable on the board, which he must have known by heart.

Thayer walked down the platform past us. He was not laughing. He came up behind Dunning in the fog and hit him between the shoulders with his fist, as hard as a big man can hit, so that it sounded on the boards, so that Dunning's hat went off and his whole body went forward a step.

Some of us shouted. Most of us didn't do anything.

Dunning did not turn around. He stood a moment where the blow had put him. Then he bent and picked up his hat, and set it on, and when the train came in out of the fog he climbed into the coach with his umbrella and his dinner, and sat down by a window on the far side, and we could see his hat through the glass, and it did not move, and it did not look back.

Thayer stood on the platform with his hand still closed. The conductor called. He got on with us.

He did not say a word to Rogers Park. He did not light his cigar. He sat with the *Tribune* on his knee and did not open it, and his face went from pink to the color of the fog, and somewhere past Ravenswood he put his face in his hands. We had seen men drunk in that car and men who had lost a year's money on wheat. We had never seen a man look like that.

At Wells Street he was off before the train stopped. We went after him. Some of us thought he meant to finish it. He ran along the cinders through the steam and the crowd off the coaches with his hat in his hand, and he caught Dunning by the newsstand, and before the whole North Western platform, before a hundred people going to work, Royal Thayer of Peoria knelt down on the boards.

Mr. Dunning, I struck you on a wager. I have no excuse. I am more ashamed than I have been in my life. Will you pardon me?

Dunning looked down at him. He was a small man. He had a small brown mustache and his collar was a little frayed.

You have it, he said. *Get up, Mr. Thayer. Your trousers.*

Thayer got up. He held on to Dunning's hand. *Then come to dinner on Sunday. Will you? Come every Sunday. Mrs. Thayer will be glad. I want you at my table.*

Thank you, Dunning said. *I will.*

He went out into Wells Street to his books. Thayer stood there by the newsstand. The rest of us stood behind him, and we did not look at each other, because every one of us was thinking the same thing, and what we were thinking was not about pardon.

III. The Gate

Sunday, the 24th

Ober's wife was one of the people who sat in Mr. Pryor's parlor on Sundays, so we knew the hour. Dunning went in at Thayer's gate at a quarter to one. By two there were nine of us outside it.

Nobody had said, *Let's.* We would like that to be understood. Gates came by Ober's house after church and said he thought he would walk down Ridge Avenue, and Ober got his hat. The village had been laying the new brick walk on the east side of Ridge since August, and there was a pile of paving brick at the corner where the workmen had left off, and a heap of broken ones beside it, and when we came to the gate most of us had a brickbat in our coat pocket or our hand, and I could not tell you which of us picked up the first one. Gates had his buggy whip. Young Hollis had a piece of lath. We were church members, all but two. We stood in the street in our Sunday coats in the thin October sun, and the leaves came down off Thayer's elms, and we could smell the dinner through his windows, roast chicken and something with cloves, and we waited for the coward to come out of his door.

He came out at half past two. Dunning was ahead of him on the walk. Thayer was carrying Dunning's umbrella for him, the way a boy carries a man's satchel, both hands, and it came to me only afterward that Dunning must have handed it to him on the step.

They saw us at the gate. Thayer stopped. He looked at our hands and he understood, and he went white again, the way he had on the train, and he did not run back into his house. He stood on his own walk holding the other man's umbrella.

Elias, Gates said. *You go on home now. Go along. This is between him and us.*

Dunning came down the walk and opened the gate and stood in it.

Mr. Gates, he said, *did Mr. Thayer strike you?*

Gates said that wasn't the point.

Did he strike you, Mr. Ober? Did he strike you, Hollis? He went along us one at a time. He asked every one of us by name, nine times, and nine times somebody had to say no. It took a long while. It was very quiet on Ridge Avenue. A leaf came down on Hollis's hat and stayed there.

He struck me, Dunning said. *And he asked my pardon, and I gave it him. So there is nothing here belongs to you. Go home to your dinners.*

Then he held out his hand behind him without looking, and Thayer put the umbrella in it, and Dunning walked out through the middle of us down Ridge Avenue toward Spring Street, and nobody stopped him. After a while we went home. I don't remember putting the brickbat down. I found it that night in my coat.

GLEN ARDEN NOTES

A number of our citizens assembled Sunday afternoon before the residence of R. Thayer, Esq., on Ridge Avenue, upon some private business, and dispersed in good order. — The new brick walk on Ridge has been found short some fourteen or fifteen bricks, and Trustee Bolles asks that any person knowing of their whereabouts return them to the corner.

IV. The Parlor

Spring Street · the same afternoon

WHAT HAPPENED NEXT WE HAVE ONLY FROM MRS. OBER, AND she says she has it right, and we have no reason to think she hasn't.

Mr. Pryor's people met at four. There were seven that day, in the front parlor full of clocks, the old man's own and other people's, ticking on every wall and shelf, none of them together. The old man was seventy-four and had made loom parts in Massachusetts before the war. He sat by the stove with a clock in pieces on a tray on his knees, the way he always did, and he hardly ever spoke. The others read and talked. He fixed the clock.

Everybody had heard about the gate by then. Miss Kittredge, who taught the fourth grade, said she had heard, too, that this was the second Sunday Mr. Dunning had eaten at that man's table, and that he meant to go every week, and she did not think it right.

It's one thing to forgive him, she said. *We all forgive him. It's another thing to sit down to his chicken every Sunday as if nothing had happened. It tells him nothing happened. A man who will hit one person from behind will hit another. Next time it will be somebody who can't bear it. It will be a woman, or a child. And it will be because Mr. Dunning let him think it was all right.*

Mr. Lund, the harness maker, said he thought so too. He said a little honest fear of consequences never hurt anybody's morals, and that those men at the gate, whatever else, had shown Thayer what the village thought. Two or three of the others nodded. Mrs. Ober says she nodded herself. Dunning was not there. He had gone home to lie down, his landlady said; his back was black and yellow from the shoulder blades to the belt.

The old man set a little brass wheel down on the tray.

What are you all talking about, he said, *sitting here?*

They told him. He listened to the whole of it with his head on one side, the way he listened to a clock that wouldn't keep time.

There were two men on that platform, he said, *and only one of them had a fist. If there had been two fists, you would have had a fight, and the rest of it never. There would be nobody now to sit at that table. There is nobody else in this village that man would let sit there.*

Miss Kittredge said, but if he strikes again.

He has been struck, Mr. Pryor said. *Did nobody see it? He was struck harder than Elias was. He went down on his knees on the Wells Street boards.* He picked up the little wheel again. *Smite not the smiter to save thine own cheek. Mr. Ballou put that in his book, when I was a young man at Hopedale. He put a good deal in it. That was the part I could carry.*

Then he said there was one more thing he had by heart, from the year he was twenty-six, when he walked to Boston for the peace meeting and sat in the gallery and heard it read out. He did not get up. He said it to the clock on his knee.

> *The history of mankind is crowded with evidences proving that physical coercion is not adapted to moral regeneration; that the sinful dispositions of men can be subdued only by love; that evil can be exterminated from the earth only by goodness; that it is not safe to rely upon an arm of flesh, upon man whose breath is in his nostrils, to preserve us from harm; that there is great security in being gentle, harmless, long-suffering, and abundant in mercy; that it is only the meek who shall inherit the earth, for the violent who resort to the sword are destined to perish with the sword.*
>
> *— Declaration of Sentiments, Peace Convention, Boston, 1838*

I am sorry for Mr. Thayer, he said. *He has had a bad week. But I am sorrier for the nine at the gate. He struck once and was sorry. They had the bricks in their hands and they are not sorry yet. That is worse.*

Mrs. Ober went home and told her husband that, word for word, at the supper table, in front of the children, and Ober got up and went out to the barn and stayed there till dark.

V. The Doorstop

November 11, 1887

Royal Thayer gave up the smoking car. We missed him. He rode in the coach with Dunning every morning after that, for years, the two of them on the same seat, the big man and the small one, and on wet mornings it was always Thayer who carried the umbrella. He never told us what they talked about. He did not stop reading the *Truth Seeker*, and Dunning did not stop going to Mr. Pryor's, and Mrs. Thayer said they argued at her table every Sunday for nine years and never once raised their voices, and that the chicken got cold.

The morning they hanged the four men at the county jail, a year and a month after, the smoking car of the 7:52 was quiet. Somebody had the *Inter Ocean* and read out the times, and nobody said anything about pulling a trap. Gates looked out of the window the whole way to Wells Street. I don't know what he was thinking. I know what I was.

I have the brickbat still. It is half a paving brick, red, with a corner of the mortar left on, and it has held the parlor door open against the lake wind for thirty years. My wife likes it there. Every time I stoop to move it I feel in my hand exactly how heavy it is, which is about as heavy as a man's fist, and I set it down again where it belongs, against the door, and the door stays.

Background

The verses

> *No one should attack a Brahmana, but no Brahmana (if attacked) should let himself fly at his aggressor! Woe to him who strikes a Brahmana, more woe to him who flies at his aggressor!*
>
> Dhammapada 389, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *It advantages a Brahmana not a little if he holds his mind back from the pleasures of life; when all wish to injure has vanished, pain will cease.*
>
> Dhammapada 390, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, people at Sāvatthī praised the elder Sāriputta, the Buddha's chief disciple, for a patience nothing could break. A brahmin of wrong views set out to provoke him and struck him hard on the back as he went for alms. Sāriputta did not even turn around. The brahmin, stricken with remorse, fell at his feet, begged pardon and invited him to take his meals at his house, and Sāriputta accepted and handed him his bowl. A crowd gathered at the door with sticks and stones to kill the brahmin, and Sāriputta asked them whether the man had struck them or him, and sent them away. The monks grumbled that he went on eating with a man who struck people. The Buddha said that one who has destroyed anger does not strike back, and spoke the verses. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta.

Glen Arden (fictional), North Shore, Illinois

Chicago's North Shore, 1886

By the 1880s the Chicago and North Western carried commuters from a string of villages along the lake into its Wells Street station, rebuilt in 1881. On May 4, 1886, a bomb thrown at police breaking up a labor rally in the Haymarket killed seven officers and led to the trial of eight anarchists; seven were sentenced to death, and four were hanged on November 11, 1887. The same decade was the height of Robert Ingersoll's fame as "the Great Agnostic," a lecturer who had practiced law in Peoria.

Mr. Pryor's nonresistance goes back to the New England Non-Resistance Society, formed at a peace convention in Boston in September 1838 that admitted women as equals; its Declaration of Sentiments was written by William Lloyd Garrison. Adin Ballou, a member, founded the Hopedale Community near Milford, Massachusetts, in 1842, a "Practical Christian" commune that failed after fourteen years and became the Draper brothers' loom-parts town. Ballou's *Christian Non-Resistance* (1846) was later admired by Tolstoy. The Declaration is quoted here from the text printed in *William Lloyd Garrison: The Story of His Life Told by His Children*, volume 2 (1885).

After the story of the elder Sāriputta from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 389–390). The original. Words from the Declaration of Sentiments of the Boston Peace Convention (1838) and Adin Ballou's *Christian Non-Resistance* (1846). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.8

May Wreath

> *With purity and with holiness I will pass my life and practise my Art.*
> *— The Oath of Hippocrates, tr. Francis Adams (1849)*

So I have heard tell, in the hill towns of Caledonia County.

I. Three Times

From the daybook of Silas Whitcomb, physician · North Calder, Vermont · May 1816

MAY 12. HARD FROST IN THE NIGHT. CORN NOT IN. RODE TO Bemis, wife, intermittent fever, bark. To the Gray children at the Hollow, all four with the hooping cough, nothing to be done but sit. .75

MAY 13. Aunt Lydia came down the hill road on foot this forenoon and sat in my kitchen and asked me to take her to read physic. She is fifty-eight. I said it could not be done, there being no precedent, and that she knew more already than half the doctors in the county, which is true, and does not answer her. She went home.

MAY 18. Freeze again, ice on the trough a finger thick. Sheep pens at Ladd's. Patience Ladd delivered of a son, Lydia attending, sent for me only to sign the paper. Nothing for me to do there. Lydia asked again on the road home. I said no.

I set down here, since a daybook is for what was owed and paid, what is owed. My mother Mercy Farrow died seven days after I was born. Her sister Lydia came over the hill the next morning with her own milk still in her, having lost a boy in March, and put me to the breast, and two years after married my father, and raised me. She taught me my letters from the almanac. She held the basin the first time I bled a man and did not spill it when I did. In the winter of '13, when the lung fever and the

spotted fever came through these towns together and Father died of it, and I was riding forty miles a day and could not be in two houses, it was Lydia and the women she brought with her who sat up in the others. Hannah Ladd, Patience Ladd, Sally Bemis, the Widow Gray, Content Spaulding. They went where she went. After the sickness passed they kept on, and she taught them to catch babies, and they meet at her kitchen once a month, at the full of the moon so as to see to walk home, and talk over their cases like a medical society. I have no answer to any of this. I am the only physician in North Calder, and she is asking me to be her master.

MAY 29. Cold again. Lydia came the third time. Said nothing of it. Mended my coat, which wanted it, and asked again at the door. I said I would think on it, which she took for the no it was. —

II. Snow in June

June 6–10

JUNE 6. RAIN WENT TO SNOW BY MORNING. IN JUNE.

JUNE 7. Snow all day, driving. Near a foot at Danville they say. Ladd's new-shorn sheep dead in the pasture, eleven of them, and I am told the same at every farm up the valley. The apple trees were in full flower. They stand in the snow white on white and the blossoms are brown by night. Rode to the Bemis place through drifts to the horse's knees. Sally Bemis there before me.

JUNE 8. Snow squalls. At dusk Lydia at my door. She had walked the four miles down from the hill in it in her house shoes, having nothing else that would do, her skirts frozen to the knee and her feet blue. She had brought her own Denman on midwifery and the case-book she has kept since '13 in a sack on her back. She did not ask again. She sat by my fire with her feet in a pail of water and the book in her lap and waited for me to say it.

I said it. God help me, I made conditions first. I wrote them on the back of a bill of Ladd's and read them to her, and I have pinned the leaf in here, so that it is in the book with the rest of what I owe.

L. W. TO READ PHYSIC WITH S. W. UPON THESE CONDITIONS

1. She shall stand aside at the bedside for any regular physician, though he be licensed but yesterday.
2. She shall send for a physician in every case of flooding, convulsions, or a cross birth, at whatever hour and distance.
3. She shall not bleed, nor give calomel or the laudanum, but by my leave.
4. She shall take no fee of the poor, and of others not more than half a physician's fee.
5. She shall not call herself Doctor, nor suffer it.
6. She shall keep a daybook and bring it to me at each full moon.
7. She shall not reprove a physician before a family, however wrong; she shall tell me after.
8. What she knows she shall teach to any woman who asks, under these same conditions.

I take them. Lydia Whitcomb

She heard them out. Then she said, *When I was a girl in Rindge, when the apple trees came out in May, we made wreaths of the blossom and put them on our own heads. Nobody had to put it on you. You took it in both hands. I will take these the same way.* And she held out her hand for the pen.

I have bled men who did not flinch less than I flinched writing the first of those. She raised me. I told her so. She said, *Then you had better do it right.*

JUNE 10. Clear and cold, moon near full. Began her on Cullen's *First Lines*, Book I, of fevers. She reads faster than I did. In the evening I read her the Oath out of my Latin, turning it to English as I went, as old Dr. Shedd did for me at Peacham when I was nineteen, and she said it after me with her hand on the book. There being in this county no other preceptor who would have her, I am her preceptor. There is no paper. There is this book.

III. Her Women

July–August

July 6. Frost. Corn black in the low fields. Hannah Ladd, ague. Paid in rye, which nobody can spare. .50

July 10. Lydia to my house for her reading, Cullen Chap. IV. I asked after the women's meeting, it being the full of the moon. She said they did not come.

July 14. It is said at Bemis's store, and it came round to me by three roads, that Lydia Whitcomb has no preceptor. That a woman cannot read physic with her own boy that she nursed. That it is a kindness and not a reading, that there was no examination and no paper and no fee, that she put the name on herself as you put on a bonnet. And the women she taught have taken it up, being made, they say, uneasy. If she had no teacher, who taught them? What are they, then? Sally Bemis would not have her at her lying-in on the 12th and sent eleven miles for Dr. Pratt, who came drunk.

July 30. Folded in here, a letter left at my door, unsigned, but I know the hand, having seen it on every one of her cases in '13.

> Doctor — We mean no disrespect to her or you. We followed her through that winter into every house and would again. But she has learnt us everything we know and now it is said she never learnt it of anybody but put it on herself, and we do not know what we are. A woman of fifty-eight cannot be a student to her own son. Folks are laughing. We cannot sit at the moon with her while it is so. We are sorry for it.
> Yr. obt. svts.

August 8. Moon near full. Lydia set out her kitchen as always, six chairs and the teapot and the case-books on the table, and sat till ten, and nobody came. I know because I sat in the dark on the wall across the road and watched her window. She did not weep. At ten she put the chairs back against the wall, one at a time, and put out the candle.

AUGUST 21. Killing frost. What corn was left is gone. The Spaulding boy, crushed foot, a log, Lydia already there and had done it well. I told her so. She said, *Condition the seventh, I am not to say a physician is wrong. Is there a condition for when he is right?* She laughed. First time since June.

IV. The Full of the Moon

September 7

SEPT. 7. I WENT ROUND TO THE FIVE OF THEM IN THE forenoon, house by house, and told each one I would be at Mrs. Whitcomb's kitchen tonight at moonrise and wished she would come and hear me, and if after that she did not want to sit with her, I would say no more. Patience Ladd shut the door. The others said they would come.

Four came, and then, late, Patience, with her shawl over her head as if it were raining.

I did not sit down. I said: You say she has no preceptor. She has. I am her preceptor. I examined her, the evening of the eighth of June, in my kitchen, with her feet in a pail, and I examined her every week since, and I would put her up against any student in the Medical Society. She has no paper because there is no paper in this State for a woman. I set her conditions before ever I set them for you, and she took them first, and she keeps them better than I keep mine. If she has no teacher, then I have none, for she taught me to read.

Hannah Ladd said, *But she is your mother.*

I said, She is, and I had no other. Then I said: You ask who taught her. Ask instead what she has done. You were in the houses with her the winter of '13. Did any one of you ever see her do a sick person harm with her hands? Did any one of you hear her carry a word out of a sickroom that ought to have stayed in it? Did you ever know her to go into a house for anything but the good of the one in the bed? Then that is the whole of it, and the rest is talk at Bemis's store.

Then I gave them the part of the Oath that I give every student, the same as I gave her, in English, as near as I can make it out of the Latin.

> *With purity and with holiness I will pass my life and practise my Art. … Into whatever houses I enter, I will go into them for the benefit of the sick, and will abstain from every voluntary act of mischief and corruption; and, further, from the seduction of females or males, of freemen and slaves. Whatever, in connexion with my professional practice, or not in connexion with it, I see or hear, in the life of men, which ought not to be spoken of abroad, I will not divulge, as reckoning that all such should be kept secret.*
>
> *— The Oath of Hippocrates, tr. Francis Adams (1849)*

I said: That is three things. What she does, what she says, what she means. I have known her thirty-one years and not found her wanting in one of them. Find it, and I will tear up the leaf.

Nobody said anything. Lydia had not said one word the whole while. She got up and took the six chairs down off the wall, one at a time, and set them round the table, and poured the tea. Sally Bemis sat down first. Patience last. They talked over their cases till the moon was behind Burke Mountain and I rode home.

SEPT. 8. No charge.

V. In Another Hand

Winter 1817

THE LAST PAGES OF THE BOOK FOR THAT YEAR ARE NOT IN HIS hand.

FEB. 2. S. W. down with the lung fever since the 28th. I keep his book till he is up, condition the sixth. Bled him myself, eight ounces, having nobody to ask leave of but him, and he gave it. Nettle broth. —

FEB. 9. S. W. sitting up. Wants his book back. Not yet.

FEB. 11. To Victory, Mrs. Hadlock, delivered of a daughter at four in the morning, Hannah Ladd with me and did the most of it. Nothing in their house but potatoes and the clover tops they dried in the fall. Took no fee, cond. the fourth. Mr. Hadlock would not have it so and paid a hedgehog, dressed, which we ate at Hannah's on the way home, and it was good.

FEB. 16. Patience Ladd came and asked would I take her niece to read with me, she being fifteen and willing. Read her the leaf. She took it in both hands. —

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who does not offend by body, word, or thought, and is controlled on these three points.*
>
> Dhammapada 391, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Mahā Pajāpatī Gotamī was the sister of the Buddha's mother, Māyā, who died seven days after his birth; she nursed him and raised him, and later became the first woman ordained. In the commentary, the Buddha gave her the eight "heavy rules" privately before they were announced, and she accepted them, and that acceptance was her ordination; she had no preceptor or teacher but the Buddha himself. The women of her retinue, whose own ordination had come through her, began to say that she had no preceptor and had put on the yellow robe by herself, and they would no longer keep the observance days with her. The Buddha told them that he was her teacher and preceptor, and that one who does no wrong by body, speech or mind is not to be held in doubt, and spoke the verse. (In the Vinaya's fuller account she asks three times, cuts her hair and walks barefoot to Vesālī, and says she accepts the eight rules as a young woman accepts a garland and sets it on her head.) Read the full commentary story, or about Mahāpajāpatī Gotamī.

North Calder (fictional), Caledonia County, Vermont

Vermont, 1816

In 1816, the Year Without a Summer, the ash of the 1815 eruption of Mount Tambora chilled the Northern Hemisphere. In northern New England hard frosts came through May; on June 6–8 snow fell across the region, with about a foot reported at Danville, in Caledonia County, and sheep and poultry died; frosts in July and late August killed most of the corn. The following winter Vermont families were reported living on such things as nettles, clover tops and hedgehogs (porcupines), and the state lost an estimated ten to fifteen thousand people to emigration westward in 1816 and 1817. Three years earlier, in 1813, the state had suffered a season of overlapping epidemics, pneumonia ("lung fever"), "spotted fever" and typhus among them; the Woodstock physician Joseph Gallup estimated some 6,400 deaths in its five worst months.

Physicians of the period were trained mostly by apprenticeship, "reading physic" for several years with an established doctor, their preceptor, sometimes adding a course of lectures such as those at Dartmouth's medical school in Hanover. The Vermont Medical Society was chartered in 1813. No American medical school granted a degree to a woman until Elizabeth Blackwell's in 1849. The Oath is quoted from Francis Adams's translation in *The Genuine Works of Hippocrates* (1849); the passage omitted at the ellipsis is the oath's promise not to cut for the stone.

After the story of Mahā Pajāpatī Gotamī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 391). The original. Words from the Oath of Hippocrates in Francis Adams's translation (1849). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.9

The Compass Card

To reckon him who taught me this Art equally dear to me as my parents.
— Hippocrates, The Oath

As it was told at morning worship, on the hill above Sligo Creek.

I. The Lane

Caroline County, Maryland · August 1906

Sadie Upton was seventeen the summer the canvasser came up the lane, and she had been skinning tomatoes since the first of the month in the top room of the canning house at Hobbs Landing, where the steam from the cookers came up through the floorboards and the girls stood in rubber aprons to the ankle. You filled a bucket and the runner took it, and the bucket came back to you with a tin check stamped with the packer's initials. At night she stood the checks on the kitchen windowsill in rows of ten, and on Saturdays she turned them into money, and most of the money went to Denton for her mother's medicine.

Her mother took Peruna for catarrh and Lydia Pinkham's Compound for the rest, and since Sadie's father went over the side of a bugeye in the Choptank two winters back, she took a good deal of both. She slept afternoons on the lounge with her mouth open. She was yellow under the eyes and short with the little ones, and sweet as anything for an hour after supper, and then she slept again. The doctor from Denton came twice and left calomel and a bill.

The cannery ran out of tomatoes early one evening, and Sadie was sitting on the back step with her feet in a pan of water when a man in a black coat came up the lane from the county road. It was August and the

coat was buttoned. He carried a satchel in one hand and nothing in the other. What she noticed first was the gate. He opened it, came through, and put the wire loop back over the post as carefully as if the gate were his own and the stock might get out. Then he came up the lane at the same pace the whole way. When the dog went for him he did not hurry and he did not stop. He looked at the ground a few yards ahead of his feet, the way a man walks who is carrying a full basin.

He took his hat off at the step and said he was selling a book, and that the proceeds went to the sanitariums, and that his name was Ashby.

What's in it?

I'm poor at the talking part, he said. *I've only been at it two years. I couldn't give you the whole of it.*

Then give me a piece of it.

He set the satchel on the step and took out a book in green cloth and opened it where a slip of paper was, and he read her four sentences in a flat Western Shore voice, without any preaching in it, the way you would read the directions on a tin.

> *Disease is an effort of nature to free the system from conditions that result from a violation of the laws of health. In case of sickness, the cause should be ascertained. Unhealthful conditions should be changed, wrong habits corrected. Then nature is to be assisted in her effort to expel impurities and to re-establish right conditions in the system.*
>
> *— Ellen G. White, The Ministry of Healing (1905), p. 127*

Sadie looked past him through the screen door at the windowsill. The rows of tin checks. The two brown bottles with the labels turned to the wall, as if the bottles were ashamed. Something in her turned over and came to rest, the way the card in her father's boat compass used to swing around and around when you set it down on the table and then stop and point. A thing that had a cause could be stopped. You found the cause, and you stopped it, and the thing stopped. It was so simple she was angry nobody had said it before.

Read it again, she said, and he did, at the same speed.

She bought the book with everything in the baking-powder tin. That night she poured the Peruna out by the hog lot, both bottles, and then she sat up in the kitchen with the green book until the lamp ran dry. By Christmas her mother was awake in the afternoons. On the first warm Sunday in March Sadie walked four miles to her cousin Cora's at Preston and read her the same four sentences on the porch, and Cora said, *Read it again,* and then, *Well,* and then nothing for a long while. In the fall of 1907 the two of them took the train to Washington with one trunk between them, to train as nurses at the sanitarium on Sligo Creek.

Brother Ashby had gone back down the lane that evening at the same pace he came up it, and latched the gate behind him.

II. The Reports

The nurses' home, Takoma Park · autumn 1909

THE *COLUMBIA UNION VISITOR* CAME TO THE READING ROOM OF the new nurses' home on Thursdays, eight pages, and Sadie read it from the back. On page seven, under the conference reports and above the notices for the camp meetings, were the Canvassers' Reports, set in small type in columns: the name of the canvasser, the county, the book, the days and hours, the orders taken, the value. She ran her finger down Chesapeake.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending October 1, 1909
>
> J. W. Ashby, Talbot Co., Md. MH 5 41 9 $13 50
>
> East by south.

Her father's compass was a brass box the size of a biscuit with a card in it marked in thirty-two points, and the glass had a crack across Nor'west that she had stopped seeing. On the inside of her trunk lid she had pinned a railroad map of Maryland and Delaware, and with a thread and a pin stuck through Takoma Park she could lay off the line to any county

in the Chesapeake Conference. She set the compass on the floorboards, let the card settle, turned herself until she faced the point, and knelt.

She did not pray to him. She was particular about that. She prayed for him, for his feet and his chest and the dogs at the gates, and then she gave thanks for the man, and then for the rest of it. Then she got into bed with her head toward the point, which in the nurses' home meant some weeks she slept with her feet against the wall and her face toward the door, and twice the preceptress, making rounds, turned her pillow back the right way while she slept.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending October 22
>
> J. W. Ashby, Queen Anne's Co., Md. MH 5 38 6 $9 00
>
> East.

She was the best in her class. Everyone said it, and Dr. Mortensen, who said very little, said it in her way, which was to send for Miss Upton when a fomentation had to reach a patient hot. Most girls lost half the heat between the steamer and the bed. Sadie wrung the flannel in the double towel and carried it down the hall folded close against her own body, and it went on the patient's chest hot enough that the patient said *Oh,* and then said nothing, and the color came. She had the anatomy by heart before Christmas of the first year. She could do a salt glow and a cold mitten friction and a hot foot bath in the time it took the others to fill the tub.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending November 5
>
> J. W. Ashby, Calvert Co., Md. MH 4 30 3 $4 50
>
> Southeast by south.

Student nurses were paid a few dollars a month. Once a month Sadie bought two dollars' worth of two-cent stamps at the Takoma post office and mailed them in a plain envelope, with no letter, care of the conference office in Baltimore, for Brother J. W. Ashby. A canvasser lived on postage and shoe leather. She could not do anything about the leather.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending November 19
>
> J. W. Ashby, St. Mary's Co., Md. MH 5 44 4 $6 00
>
> South-southeast.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending December 3
>
> J. W. Ashby, Baltimore Co., Md. MH 5 39 11 $16 50
>
> Northeast by north.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending December 17
>
> (The name did not appear.)

That week she did not know which way to kneel. She took the compass out and held it and the card swung and settled north, the way it always did, which was no help. In the end she knelt in the middle of the floor and turned slowly all the way around on her knees, a point at a time, thirty-two times, and her roommates sat up in their beds in the dark and watched her do it.

> Chesapeake, Week Ending December 31
>
> J. W. Ashby, Washington Co., Md. MH 3 22 2 $3 00
>
> Northwest, a little north of it.

III. A Letter

Slipped under the office door · January 1910

> Dear Dr. Mortensen,
>
> We write this with great reluctance and only after prayer. We do not wish to make trouble for a sister. But we believe it is our duty, as it is written that we are our brother's keeper, and we have read what Sister White has written about the deceptions of the last days and the working of spirits, and we are afraid.
>
> Every Thursday Miss Upton consults a brass compass. She has a map in her trunk with a pin in it. She kneels to a different quarter of

> the heavens each week, sometimes east, sometimes south, once to the northeast. She turns her bed around to lie toward the same quarter. Before Christmas there was a week when she knelt to all the quarters one after another, turning on her knees in the dark, and did not speak when Miss Kinney asked her what she was doing.
>
> Miss Dorsett, whose brother is at the Foreign Mission Seminary, says the Mohammedans in Egypt bow toward Mecca five times a day. But their Mecca does not move.
>
> She is the best nurse among us and we love her. That is why we have written.
>
> Respectfully,
> Ethel Kinney
> Mabel Dorsett
> Lottie Snyder

IV. The Oath

The superintendent's office · the same week

Dr. Hanne Mortensen was sixty-one. She had been born on a farm near Aalborg and brought to Wisconsin at six, and had gone to Ann Arbor for medicine when there were few enough women in the lecture room that the men counted them, and from there to Battle Creek, and from Battle Creek to Calcutta for seven years, and from Calcutta to this office with a window over the creek. She had a way of looking at a girl that the girls said was like being auscultated.

She sent for all four of them after morning worship. The three who had signed stood by the bookcase. Sadie stood by the window with her hands folded on her apron bib.

Miss Upton. These young women tell me you kneel to the points of the compass.

Sadie looked at her a while.

Doctor, she said, *you know what I kneel to.*

Dr. Mortensen did not answer her. She held out her hand to Mabel Dorsett.

Thursday's Visitor*, please. Page seven. Read me the Chesapeake.*

Mabel read the names in the order they came. Bowen, Queen Anne's County. Lankford, Somerset. Then she stopped, and read the next one slower. *J. W. Ashby. Frederick County.*

Which way is Frederick County, Miss Upton?

Northwest by north, Doctor.

I read the applications, Dr. Mortensen said to the three by the bookcase. *Every one. There is a line on the form: by what means did you come to the message. Most of you wrote the name of a parent. Miss Upton wrote the name of a canvasser who stood on her mother's back step in Caroline County and read her four sentences, because he said he could not give her any more than that. She has been turning toward that man every week for three years, wherever the* Visitor *says he has walked to. She is not bowing to the northwest. She is bowing to J. W. Ashby.*

Nobody said anything. The radiator knocked.

Dr. Mortensen got up and took a book down from the top of the case, a heavy brown volume with a broken spine, and turned to a place in it near the front.

This is the oath the old Greek physicians took. I took it, more or less, in Ann Arbor in 1879, because a professor of mine thought we ought to. I will not read you whom they swore it by. You would write me a letter. Lottie Snyder laughed and put her hand over her mouth. *But listen to what they swore.*

> *I will keep this Oath and this stipulation—to reckon him who taught me this Art equally dear to me as my parents, to share my substance with him, and relieve his necessities if required.*
>
> *— Hippocrates, The Oath, tr. Francis Adams (1849)*

She shut the book.

In Calcutta, she said, *there was a Brahmin on our street who kept a fire in a clay pot in his courtyard that his grandfather had lit. Morning and evening he fed it. He would no more have let it go out than stopped breathing. I thought it was heathen foolishness when I came. I was there seven years. When I left I thought he was the most faithful man on the street.* She looked at the three of

them. *A girl who keeps the man who first taught her the way that Brahmin kept his fire has not gone over to the spirits. Who first taught you? Do you know which way they are tonight?*

Ethel Kinney began to cry, and could not have said why.

• • •

The night nurse, coming up the stairs of the nurses' home at ten o'clock with her lamp, saw through four open doors on the second floor four girls kneeling in their nightgowns, each one facing a different way. Ethel Kinney toward Ohio and a Sabbath-school teacher in Mount Vernon who had given her a card with a lily on it in 1897. Lottie Snyder toward a grandmother in Lancaster County. Mabel Dorsett toward the wall, because her teacher had been her own mother, who was in Trenton, and she was not sure where Trenton was from Takoma Park and would not ask. Sadie Upton toward the northwest by north, with the brass box on the floor beside her and the card gone still.

The night nurse said afterward that it looked like a compass card itself, the whole floor, and that she stood on the landing and did not go up the last step until they had all got into bed.

V. The Chart

Men's ward, Washington Sanitarium · February 1910

He came in on the afternoon train from Frederick with a canvasser's cough that had gone down into his chest a week before and stayed there. Somebody at the Frederick church had put him on the car. He walked from the Takoma station up the hill with his satchel, at the same pace, and fainted on the sanitarium steps.

> **Ashby, J. W.** age 53 colporteur adm. 4:40 p.m.
> Lobar pneumonia, right lower lobe. T. 104.2. P. 120. R. 36. Rusty sputum.

> Orders: hot fomentations to chest q. 2 hrs, 3 changes each, followed by cold mitten friction. Water freely. Night special: Miss Upton.

He did not know her. She had been a girl on a step with her feet in a pan of water, and now she was a nurse in a cap with her sleeves rolled, and he was a man with a fever of a hundred and four who thought for an hour around midnight that he was back in Calvert County and the dog had his satchel. She did not tell him. She brought the fomentations down the hall folded against her own body, three changes, and laid them on his chest so hot that he said *Oh,* and then nothing, and she rubbed his arms with the cold mitten until the skin came up pink, and she counted his breaths with her watch.

> 11:00 Fom. to chest x 3. C.M.F. T. 104.4. Restless. Asks for his books.
> 1:00 Fom. x 3. T. 104.0. Delirious, mild. Talking of a gate.
> 3:00 Fom. x 3. T. 104.6. R. 40. Pulse weak. Dr. M. notified.

Dr. Mortensen came at a quarter past three in a wrapper with her hair down her back in a grey braid, and listened to his chest for a long time, and said, *Keep them hot,* and went and sat in the chair by the door and did not go back to bed.

At four he was quiet and his lips were blue at the edges. Sadie had the steamer going in the diet kitchen across the hall and she did not let it drop off the boil for a minute, and every time she came back through the door with the flannel against her she looked at Dr. Mortensen in the chair, and Dr. Mortensen looked back at her, and neither of them said anything.

Between changes she sat by the bed. His satchel was on the floor under it, where the orderly had put it. She took out the green book, which was the same edition, a little more worn, with the slip of paper still in it at the same page, and she read him the four sentences in a low voice at the same speed he had read them to her, without any preaching in it.

> 5:00 Fom. x 3. Profuse sweating. T. 101.2.
> 5:40 Crisis. T. 99.0. P. 88. Sleeping naturally.

He woke at seven with the light coming grey off the creek and looked at her a long time, the way a man does who is trying to put a face to a county.

Do I know you?

You sold my mother a book. In Caroline County.

Did it do her any good?

Yes, sir.

He thought about that, and then he closed his eyes. *I never could tell it right,* he said. *I only ever had the one piece of it.*

Dr. Mortensen stood up out of the chair by the door and went out without a word, and Sadie heard her going down the hall in her slippers. The brass box was in Sadie's apron pocket. She took it out and set it on the night table by the water glass, and the card went round once and settled north, as it always did, and she let it, and went across the hall to warm the next flannel.

Background

The verse

> *After a man has once understood the law as taught by the Well-awakened (Buddha), let him worship it carefully, as the Brahmana worships the sacrificial fire.*
>
> Dhammapada 392, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Sāriputta, the wisest of the Buddha's disciples, first heard the Dhamma from the elder Assaji, a quiet monk whose bearing on his alms round caught his eye. Assaji said he was new and could give only a little, and spoke four lines about causes and their ending; Sāriputta understood at once. From then on, wherever Assaji was staying, Sāriputta bowed in that direction and even lay down to sleep with his head toward it. Other monks decided he had gone back to worshipping the directions and reported him. When the Buddha asked, Sāriputta left the answer to the Buddha's own knowledge, and the Buddha explained that he was honoring the teacher through whom he had learned, as a Brahmin honors the sacred fire. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta and Assaji.

Takoma Park, Maryland

Takoma Park, 1909

Takoma Park was laid out in 1883 as a commuter suburb on the B&O's Metropolitan Branch just outside Washington. In 1904 the Seventh-day Adventist Church bought land there along Carroll Avenue and moved its headquarters from Battle Creek, Michigan; the church's publishing house, college and the Washington Sanitarium followed. The sanitarium opened on June 13, 1907, on the bank of Sligo Creek, treating patients with water, air, massage and plain food. It trained nurses from the start, and a nurses' dormitory went up in 1909. Hot fomentations, salt glows and cold mitten frictions were the ordinary tools of Adventist hydrotherapy.

Ellen G. White's *The Ministry of Healing* (1905) was a "relief book": she gave up her royalties, the publishers printed it at cost, and church members sold it door to door to help pay the debts of the denomination's sanitariums. Canvassers' weekly results, by name, county, book, hours and orders, were printed in union papers such as the *Columbia Union Visitor*. The book appeared the same year Samuel Hopkins Adams's series "The Great American Fraud" in *Collier's* exposed patent medicines like Peruna, which was largely alcohol; the Pure Food and Drug Act followed in 1906. On the Eastern Shore, girls and women of Sadie's age spent the summer peeling tomatoes at piece rates in the canning houses, paid in tokens for each bucket.

After the story of Sāriputta and Assaji from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 392). The original. Quotations from Ellen G. White, *The Ministry of Healing* (1905), and Hippocrates, *The Oath*, tr. Francis Adams (1849). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.10

For A' That

The rank is but the guinea's stamp,
The Man's the gowd for a' that.
— Robert Burns

The way we tell it, in Parma.

> WEST RIDGE PIPES & DRUMS
> Annual Burns Supper
> Sokol Hall, Ridge Road · Wednesday, January 25, 1978 · 6:30 p.m. · $9.50
> Piping In · Selkirk Grace · Piping In of the Haggis · Address to a Haggis · The Immortal Memory · Toast to the Lassies · Reply · Auld Lang Syne

I. Piping In

Sokol Hall · 6:30 p.m.

There were fourteen of us that winter, if you count Murdo, and you had to count Murdo. Six pipers, four snares, two tenors, Danny Kovac on the bass, and Pipe Major Murdo MacAskill, who was seventy-one and had been born in a black house in Glendale on the Isle of Skye and had come to Cleveland by way of the Clydebank yards in 1949 and been a millwright at the GM plant on Chevrolet Boulevard until they gave him his pin. We practiced Tuesday nights in the basement of the Methodist church on Pearl Road with the Sunday-school chairs stacked against the wall. Most of us had never been to Scotland. Danny was Slovak. Lesia Hnatiuk was sixteen and Ukrainian Catholic, and practiced in

her father's garage on Snow Road with the door up in all weathers because her mother would not have it in the house. The Szabo twins were Hungarian. Two of the snares were Methodists from Brook Park whose grandfather might have been Scotch, they said, or Welsh. We had learned the pipes from Murdo the way you learn anything from a man who does not talk much, by doing it wrong in front of him until he stopped wincing.

Murdo called three people in his life a piper. One was a man named Angus Lamont who had taught him in a tenement in Clydebank and was killed in the Blitz there in 1941. One was old Joe Szabo, the twins' grandfather, who had played at every funeral at the VA hospital for twenty years whether or not anybody had asked him. The third was Lesia. He had started calling her that in October, the first week the frost was on the garage floor, when he drove by on Snow Road at seven in the morning and heard her in there going over the same four bars of a strathspey with the door up and her breath showing. He came to practice that Tuesday and said, *Piper, give us the tune,* and it took her a second to understand he meant her, and then she went red to the hair and gave us the tune.

Don McCrimmon had been with us since May. He was forty-four and sold water softeners, the regional man for the whole west side, and knew the inside of more Parma basements than the gas company. He was a decent man and an awful piper. He had come to us the spring after *Roots* was on, when half the country was writing away for its grandparents. Don wrote to a genealogy society in Edinburgh and paid them sixty dollars and they wrote back that McCrimmon was MacCrimmon, and that the MacCrimmons had been the hereditary pipers to the chiefs of MacLeod of Dunvegan, on Skye, for generations, and had kept a school of piping at a place called Borreraig.

After that Don grew a beard. It came in red, which surprised everybody, Don included. Bev, his wife, ordered him a kilt in MacLeod tartan from a house in Edinburgh, because the MacCrimmons as far as she could find had no sett of their own, and a plaid to go over the shoulder, and a badge for the plaid with the MacLeod bull's head on it, and he wore the whole of it to practice, every Tuesday, in the church basement,

under the Sunday-school pictures of Jesus with the lambs. He had a set of African blackwood pipes with silver mounts that cost more than Danny's car. He blew them like a man inflating a raft.

He never said anything about Lesia. But we saw him look at her when Murdo said *Piper.*

That night we piped the guests in out of a cold rain, the drones going and the rain coming down slantwise in the light over the Sokol hall door, eighty of them, Methodists and Slovaks and the Scottish society people from Lakewood in their good kilts, and Don's wife Bev in a tartan sash, and Lesia's father, who had come to see what all the noise in his garage had been for.

II. Piping In of the Haggis

7:40 p.m.

The haggis came from a butcher on Lorain Avenue who made it for the Scottish societies every January, and it was American, which meant there were no lungs in it. You couldn't have sheep lung in food in this country since 1971. Murdo said every year that an American haggis was a haggis in the way a wax apple was an apple, and every year he addressed it anyway. Danny carried it in on a silver tray behind Lesia, who piped it in, and Murdo stood up at the head table with a knife from the Sokol kitchen and gave it the whole address in a voice we had never heard him use, the voice, Bev said afterward, of a man in a pulpit in Skye. When he came to the cutting he cut, and it steamed, and everybody clapped. Then he sat down and ate a little of it, and said it was very good, and it was not.

Outside the rain had stopped sounding like rain.

III. The Immortal Memory

9:15 p.m.

Don gave the Immortal Memory. He had asked for it in November, and Murdo had said *Fine,* and Don had been working on it

since Thanksgiving in his den on a yellow legal pad. It ran thirty-five minutes. It was about Burns, some of it. Mostly it was about Skye, which Don had never seen, and the MacCrimmons at Borreraig, and the clans, and the blood. *Blood,* he said, *remembers. Some of us in this hall are here because we like the music. Some of us are here because we can't help it. Because the music's in us from three hundred years back.* He looked at the head table when he said it. He finished with a verse from "Scots, Wha Hae," and the Lakewood people stood up and cheered, and Danny's mother, who was from Bratislava, clapped politely, and Lesia looked at her plate.

Murdo stood and raised his glass to the Immortal Memory with the rest of us. He did not say anything about the speech. He looked, we thought, tired.

At a quarter to eleven somebody opened the side door to go out for a smoke and the door was pulled out of his hand.

IV. The Storm

Thursday, January 26 · after midnight

It came up out of the south and west, and by one o'clock the wind was over fifty, and some time before three the rain turned to snow, and the snow did not fall so much as go by. The windows of the Sokol hall went white and stayed white. You could not see the cars in the lot. You could not see the lot. The radio in the kitchen said to stay off the roads, and then that the Turnpike was closed, and then that the National Guard was being called out, and then the power went off for a long minute and came back with the lights a little browner than before. Eighty people at a Burns supper looked at each other in their kilts and good dresses and understood they would be sleeping on a gymnasium floor.

We pushed the tables to the walls. The Sokol ladies made coffee in the big urns. Somebody found the gym mats and somebody found the flags from the Slovak national days and people slept under the flags. Murdo sat

on a folding chair by the coffee with his pipes across his knees and his eyes shut. He was not asleep. Murdo never slept that we knew of.

It was close to four o'clock when Don came and stood in front of him. He had been drinking a little, the toasts and then the bottle the Lakewood men had passed around after the power came back, but not so much that it did all the talking. He still had the plaid on, pinned with the bull's head. His beard was in a mat from lying on it.

Murdo, he said. *Can I ask you something.*

Murdo opened his eyes.

You call her a piper. He didn't point. He didn't have to. Lesia was asleep against the wall bars under a Slovak flag with her pipe case for a pillow. *She's sixteen. She's been playing a year and a half. She's Ukrainian, Murdo. Her folks came over after the war. There isn't a drop of Scotch in her.* His voice wasn't angry. That was the worst of it. It was the voice of a man who had been holding something in a long time. *My people were pipers to MacLeod for three hundred years. On Skye. Your island. I've got it in a letter from Edinburgh. I've got the tartan, I've got the blood, I come every Tuesday. I'd just like to know what it is I don't have.*

People were awake by then, around the urn and on the mats. We were all awake. Bev was sitting up with her coat around her shoulders.

Murdo looked at him for a long time. Then he said, quietly, so that we had to lean to hear him over the wind:

Donald. I don't call anybody a piper for his kilt. Or his name. Or whose grandson he is. My own grandfather crofted two miles from Borreraig and he couldn't play a note, and he was the best man in Glendale. He was quiet a moment. *You did the Immortal Memory and you left out the best one.*

And he said it to him sitting down, in the brown light, not in the pulpit voice. In his own.

Is there for honest Poverty
That hings his head, an' a' that;
The coward slave—we pass him by,
We dare be poor for a' that!
For a' that, an' a' that.
Our toils obscure an' a' that,
The rank is but the guinea's stamp,
The Man's the gowd for a' that.

A prince can mak a belted knight,
A marquis, duke, an' a' that;
But an honest man's abon his might,
Gude faith, he maunna fa' that!
For a' that, an' a' that,
Their dignities an' a' that;
The pith o' sense, an' pride o' worth,
Are higher rank than a' that.

— Robert Burns, "A Man's a Man for A' That" (1795)

The guinea's stamp, Murdo said, *is the king's head they put on the coin. It's not the gold. That girl was in a garage at seven in the morning in October with the door up, playing the same four bars until they were right. Nobody was listening but the cat. That's the gold.*

Don did not say anything. He stood there in his plaid. The wind hit the building on the lake side so hard that the flags on the wall bars lifted.

We have argued since, the fourteen of us, about what happened in that hall then, and nobody can say it well. Danny says it was like the moment the drones strike in together and the whole room goes into tune and you feel it in your teeth. One of the Szabo twins says it was nothing, it was four in the morning and we were tired. But Danny's mother, who had come from Bratislava with one suitcase in 1949 and had sat through thirty-five minutes on the blood of the clans, put her face in her hands, and Lesia's father got up off his mat and went and stood by his daughter without waking her, and one of the Lakewood men in a good kilt said *Aye,* and then *aye* again, softer, as if he had been told something about

himself. We all of us thought of our names. Hnatiuk. Kovac. Szabo. McCrimmon. MacAskill. What was in them, and what wasn't.

V. Toast to the Lassies

Thursday · first light

AT SIX THE FURNACE QUIT.

The Sokol custodian went down to the boiler room and came back up and said it was the flue, the snow had drifted over the vent on the lot side of the building and it was backing up and he had shut it off before it put us all to sleep for good. Nobody could open the lot-side door. The wind had packed it shut.

It was Don who knew where the vent was. He had sold a softener to the Sokol in 1974 and been in that boiler room, and he knew how the pipe ran out through the block wall and where it came up on the outside, behind the dumpster, eighteen inches off the ground, under, by then, about six feet of snow. He went out the front door, which faced away from the wind, with a coal shovel from the boiler room and the custodian's flashlight, and went around the building on his hands and knees in the kilt.

He was gone forty minutes. Bev stood at the front door with it open a crack the whole time. When he came back his beard was a solid block of ice and his knees were red and raw and he could not open his hands. But the custodian went down and lit the boiler and in a quarter of an hour the radiators began to knock.

We sat Don down by the urn and Bev and Danny's mother held his hands in a dishpan of lukewarm water, and he didn't say anything, and after a while he stood up. Snow was still coming in under the double doors at the front in a little white tongue across the floor. He looked at it. Then he took the bull's head badge off his shoulder and put it in his sporran, and unwound the plaid, all eight yards of MacLeod, and knelt down and rolled it tight and packed it along the bottom of the doors, the way you'd lay a sandbag, and pressed it in with his ruined hands until no more snow came through.

Murdo watched him do it. He didn't say anything.

• • •

Lesia woke up and wanted to know what she had missed, and nobody could tell her. So Murdo asked her for a tune instead, a slow one, and she got out her pipes and stood up in the middle of the gym floor among the mats and the Slovak flags and the eighty people in yesterday's clothes and struck in her drones and played "MacCrimmon Will Never Return," because it was the slow air she knew best, she said afterward, and she hadn't thought about the name.

Don sat on the floor by the door with his back against the wall and his hands in his lap and his eyes shut. The ice in his beard was melting and running down into his collar. He was listening with his whole face, the way Murdo always told us to listen, and nobody said anything to him, then or later. Behind him the plaid lay along the bottom of the doors, and the snow outside drifted up against it and stopped there in a long ridge, and held.

Background

The verse

> *A man does not become a Brahmana by his platted hair, by his family, or by birth; in whom there is truth and righteousness, he is blessed, he is a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 393, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

A Brahmin with matted hair, born of a Brahmin family, noticed that the Buddha called his own monks "Brahmins," and came to ask that the Buddha call him one too, since he was one by birth. The Buddha answered that he did not call anyone a Brahmin for his matted hair, his clan or his birth, but only for the truth and the Dhamma in him, and spoke the verse. Many who heard it reached the first stage of awakening. The whole story is only a few lines long. Read the full commentary story.

Parma, Ohio

Parma, 1978

Parma, south of Cleveland, boomed after the Second World War into one of the largest suburbs in Ohio, home to General Motors and to large Ukrainian, Slovak, Polish and Hungarian Catholic communities; Cleveland television hosts made a running joke of its white socks and pink flamingos. In January 1977 the ABC miniseries Roots ran eight nights in a row and set off a wave of family-history research across the country. Scottish heritage societies, clan associations and amateur pipe bands grew with it. A Burns supper on or near January 25, Robert Burns's birthday, follows an old order: piping in, the Selkirk Grace, the haggis piped in and addressed, the Immortal Memory, the toasts. Since 1971 American haggis has been made without sheep's lung, which U.S. food rules forbid.

The Great Blizzard of 1978 struck the Ohio Valley and Great Lakes from January 25 to 27. Rain turned to heavy snow before dawn on the 26th, with winds strong enough to bring zero visibility all day. It was the worst blizzard in Ohio history: 51 people died, more than 5,000 National Guard troops were called out, and the whole Ohio Turnpike closed for the first time. The MacCrimmons were pipers for generations to the chiefs of Clan MacLeod, based at Borreraig near Dunvegan on Skye, where they kept a piping college. "MacCrimmon Will Never Return" is one of the best-known laments for the pipes.

After the story of the Brahmin with matted hair from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 393). The original. Verse from Robert Burns, "A Man's a Man for A' That" (1795). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.11

Shadow Work

> *Tell your beads, paint your forehead with the mark of your God, and wear matted locks long and showy: but a deadly weapon is in your heart.*
> *— Kabir, tr. Rabindranath Tagore*

This is as I set it down, in the tents at Ocean Grove.

I. No. 41

Ocean Grove, New Jersey · July 1896

Minnie Lathrop was thirteen that summer and a corresponding member of the St. Nicholas Agassiz Association, Chapter 512, Newark, and she kept a Record. The Association asked its members to observe closely, to describe exactly, to set down only what they had seen with their own eyes, and to mark plainly whatever they had only been told. She had a green cloth notebook from the stationer's on Broad Street, and a pencil on a string, and by the middle of July she had forty species of the Grove in it, from the fiddler crabs on the Wesley Lake mud to the black skimmers that came over the surf at dusk dragging their lower bills along the water as if they were ruling lines.

Her family had a tent on Pilgrim Pathway for the season, as they had every summer since she could remember, a striped canvas front with a wooden cottage built on behind it for the kitchen. Her father came down from his drugstore on Friday nights on the train. Her mother went to the Great Auditorium twice a day, and to the Young People's Meeting, and to the Holiness Meeting, and on Sundays the gates of the Grove were chained at both ends and no wheel turned on any street, and the only sound from morning service to supper was the surf and the hymns.

On the second Monday in July she made an entry she was not sure of.

No. 41. Fakir, Hindoo (so called).

Observed from the Grove side of the Wesley Lake footbridge, 7 a.m., hanging by the backs of his knees from the low limb of the big willow on the Asbury Park bank. Head down. Arms crossed on breast. Hair very long, black, matted into ropes, hanging nearly to the ground. Wears a goatskin with the hair on, tied at the waist, and nothing else that can be seen. Face painted white across the forehead in three lines. Eyes shut. Does not appear to sway. A tin cup on the grass below him. A card on the tree: YOGI RAM DASS OF BENARES. UNDER A VOW.

Length of time hanging: not known. Was there at seven. Was there at noon. Was there at six.

A man in a checked suit who called himself the Yogi's manager stood by the tree and explained the vow to anyone who stopped, and by Tuesday everybody had stopped. The Yogi had come from the banks of the Ganges, said the manager, by way of London, to hang between earth and heaven as the holy men of India did, and he would not come down until the vow was satisfied. And if he fell before it was satisfied, said the manager, lowering his voice, the gods of his country had promised him that the place where he fell would be taken by the sea.

Everybody in the Grove knew it was heathen nonsense. The Camp Meeting Association said so from the Auditorium platform on Wednesday. But Ocean Grove lies low, between a lake and the open Atlantic, and there was hardly a family on Pilgrim Pathway that did not remember a September when the surf came over the bulkhead and up the avenues, and Mrs. Tilton in the next tent said she did not believe a word of it but she did not see the harm in being on the safe side.

II. The Subscription

Pinned to the willow · the third week of July

THE VOW, IT TURNED OUT, COULD BE SATISFIED. THE MANAGER had it written out. One hundred dollars in silver. A suit of clothes. A railroad ticket to Philadelphia. And a girl to sit by the Yogi with a fan through the heat of the day and bring him his rice, because a holy man under a vow could not lift his own hand to his mouth.

Several of the Asbury Park hotel men, who did not want a dead Hindoo hanging in a tree across from their verandas in the height of the season, got up a paper. Minnie copied it into the Record, all of it, because the Association said to set down everything exactly.

Copy of the subscription, as pinned.

For the Satisfaction of the Yogi's Vow, & his Prompt Removal.

A Hotel Proprietor $20.00
The Boardwalk Merchants 15.00
A Friend of the Grove 10.00
Mrs. H. Tilton, Pilgrim Pathway 2.00
A Methodist Who Does Not Believe in It 5.00
Bathing pavilion, one suit of clothes, gentleman's, gray
Two Ladies, To Be On the Safe Side 1.00
Sundry, in the cup 48.65

The hotel on Ocean Avenue lent a chambermaid named Bridget for the fan, at the hotel's expense, for one week. She was seventeen, from County Mayo, and she sat on a camp stool under the willow in her uniform with a palmetto fan and a bowl of rice and said her beads under her breath all day long, and would not look up at the Yogi's face, which hung about a foot above her own.

On the first of August the manager announced that the vow was satisfied. That evening, with a crowd on both banks of the lake and on the footbridge, the Yogi untucked his knees from the limb and came down hand over hand by a rope the manager threw him, slowly, like a man very weak, and was helped into a hack and driven away toward the depot. The crowd clapped. Mrs. Tilton said she felt a good deal easier. Bridget went back to the hotel with the fan.

III. Mr. Gani

The boardwalk, Asbury Park

MR. GANI SOLD HANDKERCHIEFS.

He walked the Asbury Park boardwalk end to end all day with a bundle in a white cloth on his shoulder, and when a lady stopped him he set the bundle down on the rail and undid the knot, and there were handkerchiefs and table runners and children's collars and a few long scarves, all of white cotton so fine you could read through it, all worked in white thread. He wore a little white cap and a long coat and spoke English slowly and well. He was from a district called Hooghly, on a river in Bengal, he said, and there were other men from his villages who sold the same work in Atlantic City and New Orleans and Charleston. His name was Abdul Gani Mondal. The ladies of the Grove called him the Hindoo, and he did not correct them, though Minnie found out from him later that he was a Mussulman and had been to the mosque in Calcutta, and that the Yogi's card was spelled wrong.

Minnie had bought a handkerchief from him in June with her birthday quarter, and after that she stopped by him every afternoon she was let over the footbridge, because he knew the names of things. He knew the

black skimmers. He had seen birds like them on the river at home. He knew what a horseshoe crab was and that it was not a crab. He had a nephew, Rafiq, fourteen, who carried the second bundle and could add up a sale in his head faster than her father.

In the second week the Yogi was in the tree, Minnie had asked him what he thought.

Mr. Gani had walked over to the willow with his bundle on his shoulder and stood a while among the people looking. Then he said something up to the Yogi in a language she did not know, quietly, the way you'd ask a man on a train if a seat was taken. The Yogi opened his eyes and looked at him upside down for a moment, and shut them again, and said in a deep voice, *Om. Om. Ram.*

Mr. Gani nodded, as if he had been answered, and walked back to the boardwalk. He did not say anything to the crowd. He did not put anything in the cup.

What did you ask him? said Minnie.

Which village he was from, said Mr. Gani. *And whether his mother was well.*

IV. No. 42

Cookman Avenue · the second week of August

No. 42. The same.

Observed through the front window of a chop house on Cookman Avenue, about half past one, while waiting for Rafiq, who had gone in the side door to sell a table runner to the proprietor's wife. Hair cut short. Gray suit. Derby hat on the chair beside him. Right way up. Eating fried clams, a beefsteak, and a dish of stewed tomatoes. Two bottles of sarsaparilla. Has gained flesh. Identified by the ears (pierced) and a white mark of paint not quite washed out of the left eyebrow. Rafiq agrees.

When Rafiq came out, the man in the gray suit came out behind him, picking his teeth, and saw Minnie on the curb with her notebook, and must have known her, because she had stood under the willow every day for three weeks. He looked at her a long moment. Then he winked, and tipped the derby, and said in a voice from somewhere around Paterson:

Got everything I came for, sis.

He walked off toward the depot swinging his arms. Minnie found that she was shaking, and could not have said if it was anger or something else. Rafiq spat in the gutter, very neatly, and then looked around to be sure his uncle had not seen.

V. No. 43

The boardwalk rail · that afternoon

They told Mr. Gani, both of them at once. He went on folding a table runner while they talked, in thirds and then in half, the way he always did, so the work was inside.

He was like this before, too, he said when they were done. *That kind does not change his ways from one life to another. In my district there was a fakir just the same. Maybe this one. Who knows.* He set the runner on the pile. *You want the story? Write it down, then. Write that you did not see it.*

Minnie opened the Record.

Near a village outside Chinsurah, Mr. Gani said, there lived a fakir in a little hut at the edge of the rice, with long matted hair and a goatskin, and a family in the village fed him every day because he was holy. Behind his hut was an old white-ant hill, taller than a man, and in the ant-hill lived a gosaap, which is a great lizard as long as Rafiq, brown and slow, with a forked tongue and a tail like a whip. It was very old. In the evenings it came out of its hole and sat in the dust near the fakir's door, the way the old men of the village sat near a holy man in the evenings, because it believed he was one.

Now some of the people of that district eat gosaap, said Mr. Gani, though his own people did not, and one day the family that fed the fakir caught one and cooked it with onions and chilis, and sent him a portion.

He ate it and could think of nothing else. He sat in his hut and thought about the taste of it all that night and all the next day. In the evening, when the old gosaap came out of the ant-hill to sit by his door, the fakir lay down on his mat as if he were asleep, with a heavy stick hidden under his goatskin.

But the gosaap was old, and it had sat with many holy men. It came out of the hole and stopped, and looked at the fakir sleeping with one eye a little open, and smelled the smell of the cooking still on his hands, and it turned around and went back toward the hole. The fakir jumped up and threw the stick. It hit the ant-hill an inch above the gosaap's tail, and the gosaap went down into the dark.

Then the fakir called after it, sweetly. *Come out, brother. Come out, I was only playing. I have rice for you, and salt, and oil, and chili.*

And the gosaap said, from deep in the ant-hill: *What is your long hair for, fool? What is your goatskin for? Outside you are washed and painted. Inside you there is a jungle full of teeth. Keep your rice and your salt and your oil. I have seen the stick.*

Mr. Gani tied the white cloth over his bundle and knotted it.

We have a poet, he said, *a weaver, Kabir. The singers who go up and down our river sing him.* He said something in his own language, four lines, sing-song, the way the girls at school said the times tables, and then he gave it to them in English, slowly, a word at a time, as near as he could: that a man could tell his beads, and paint his forehead, and wear his hair long and matted for show, and still carry a killing weapon in his heart; and then how would he find God?

And the gosaap? said Minnie, with her pencil up. *What became of the gosaap?*

Mr. Gani lifted the bundle to his shoulder.

Some old fellow, he said, *who stayed in his hole and did not come out for rice.*

No. 43. Gosaap, or great lizard of Bengal.

NOT SEEN. Described by Mr. A. G. Mondal of Hooghly. Brown. As long as a boy of fourteen. Lives in the ant-hills. Slow, but not a fool.

That night on Pilgrim Pathway she lay on her cot under the canvas with the surf going and could not sleep. She kept seeing two things at once, the Yogi upside down with his eyes shut and the man in the gray suit picking his teeth, and she understood for the first time in her life that they were the same thing, and that a person could be both at once, and that she could be, and that it would show from the outside only if somebody very patient were watching from a hole. Rafiq, she found out the next day, had not slept either.

VI. The New Books

The public library, Asbury Park · November 1916

Twenty years later Miss Minnie Lathrop, assistant librarian, unpacked a shipment of new books from Macmillan at the back table and wrote the accession numbers inside the covers. One was a thin blue book, *Songs of Kabir*, translated by Rabindranath Tagore, who had won the Nobel Prize three years before and whose picture had been in all the papers. She had the pen in her hand to number it. Instead she sat down on the high stool and read it through, while the radiator ticked and the November light went off the windows, and under the numeral LXVII she found it.

> *I do not know what manner of God is mine.*
>
> *The Mullah cries aloud to Him: and why? Is your Lord deaf? The subtle anklets that ring on the feet of an insect when it moves are heard of Him.*
>
> *Tell your beads, paint your forehead with the mark of your God, and wear matted locks long and showy: but a deadly weapon is in your heart, and how shall you have God?*
>
> *— Songs of Kabir LXVII, tr. Rabindranath Tagore (1915)*

She did not know where Mr. Gani was. He had come back to the boardwalk two more summers and then not again. Rafiq had written her a postal card from New Orleans in 1903, in a good round hand, about a

bird he had seen there. In the papers that month there was talk in Congress of a law to close the whole of Asia to immigrants, a line drawn across the map, and she had read it standing up at the newspaper rack and thought of the white bundle on the boardwalk rail and the knot.

She still had the handkerchief from her birthday quarter. It was in her desk, in the drawer with the stamp pads. She took it out and held it up between her face and the lamp, the way he had shown her to the first day, in June of 1896, when she had complained that she could not see the pattern. From the front the cotton was plain, so fine you could read through it. Then the light came through from behind, and the flowers and the vines came up in it, gray and soft, all over, from the other side. *The work is on the inside,* he had said. *You look through to it.*

She wrote in the Kabir the accession number, and the date, and then, very small, under the number on the inside of the cover, in pencil, where the borrowers would never think to look: *No. 43. Seen.*

Background

The verse

> *What is the use of platted hair, O fool! what of the raiment of goat-skins? Within thee there is ravening, but the outside thou makest clean.*
>
> Dhammapada 394, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

A fraudulent Brahmin took a "bat vow" and hung upside down from a tree by the gate of Vesālī, demanding a hundred coins, a servant girl and other gifts, and threatening that if he fell the city would be destroyed. Afraid for their city, the people gave him everything. When monks later saw him strolling about and he told them he had got what he wanted, the Buddha said he had been a fraud in an earlier life too: an ascetic with matted hair and a deerskin who, after tasting monitor-lizard meat, tried to club the old lizard that came each evening from an ant-hill to sit near him. The wise lizard saw through the pretended sleep, escaped into the ant-hill, refused his offers of rice, salt, oil and pepper, and rebuked him with the verse. The ascetic was the same man; the lizard was the Buddha. Read the full commentary story. The lizard (*godhā*) is the Bengal monitor, which shelters in burrows and old termite mounds and is still eaten in parts of South Asia.

Ocean Grove and Asbury Park, New Jersey

Ocean Grove and Asbury Park, 1896

Ocean Grove was founded in 1869 by Methodist clergymen as a seaside camp-meeting ground. Families rented tents for the season, its Great Auditorium was finished in 1894, and until 1981 its laws barred horses, wagons and later cars from its streets on Sundays, with chains across the entrances. Its northern neighbor across Wesley Lake, Asbury Park, was laid out in 1871 by the brush manufacturer James A. Bradley as a dry Methodist resort and grew a boardwalk, pavilions and hotels. The Agassiz Association, founded in 1875, enrolled thousands of young naturalists in local chapters and for years used *St. Nicholas* magazine as its organ.

From the 1880s on, Muslim peddlers from villages in the Hooghly district of Bengal sold embroidered cotton (*chikan*) and other "Oriental" goods on the boardwalks of Atlantic City and Asbury Park, and spread through a network reaching New Orleans, Charleston and Chattanooga, a history recovered in Vivek Bald's *Bengali Harlem*. The fine shadow work of chikankari is stitched on the reverse of sheer cloth and seen through it from the front. Rabindranath Tagore's translation of *Songs of Kabir*, made with Evelyn Underhill, was published in New York by Macmillan in 1915; the Immigration Act of 1917, passed that February over President Wilson's veto, created the "Asiatic Barred Zone."

After the story of the fraudulent Brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 394). The original. Verse from *Songs of Kabir*, tr. Rabindranath Tagore (1915). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.12

Cast Clouts

The best clad English-man,
Not cloth'd with Christ, more naked is
Than naked Indian.
— Roger Williams, A Key into the Language of America (1643), ch. XX

Thus have I heard it, on the Towne Street at Providence.

I. Informations

Pawtuxet, under the government of the Massachusetts · 20 September 1647

INFORMATIONS TAKEN BEFORE ME, NATHANIEL HARROWE, a magistrate of the Bay, at a house at Pawtuxet, concerning a woman of the plantation of Providence, Thomasine Ashby, widow, called the Lath, who is reported to go through the air.

> **Ephraim Tull,** aged fourteen or thereabout, saith: That on a night in August last he was at the falls of the Moshassuck with a lantern to take eels, and saw a woman come down the river in the air, at the height of the tallest pine, not swimming nor walking, but going as a heron goes, with her arms at her sides. That she had on a coat of many pieces and a man's hat tied under her chin with a list of cloth. That she came down on the flat rock below the falls and sat. That he knew her for the Lath, who has a hut in the woods above the falls. That he was afraid and put out his lantern, and could not get home past her, and so sat in the dark until it was light, and she sat also, and did nothing in all that while, not so much as turn her head. That in the morning she said, Good morrow, Ephraim, the eels are under the

bank, and went up into the woods on her feet. That the eels were under the bank.

Joan Pratley, wife of Robert Pratley, aged about forty, saith: That she knew the said Thomasine at Boston, in the church there, when she was a goodwife in a good gown and a lawn band and had a husband. That the husband was one of those whose arms were taken from them in the year 1637 for setting their hands to the writing for Mr. Wheelwright, and they came away to Providence. That the husband was killed in the year 1640 felling an oak, and the child, a boy of two years, died of a flux the summer after. That the said Thomasine carried the child up and down the Towne Street two days asking physick at every door, and old Overy, who fishes the cove, told her to go to every lot and ask whether any had yet been laid in the ground there. That she went, and came back without the child, and said, Every one, and the town not five years old. That soon after she gave away her gown and her band and her shoes, and has gone ever since in what other folk put off. That she will take nothing given her new, only what is done with. That she eats so little you may see the veins in the backs of her hands and in the side of her neck, as in a leaf held up to the window. That this deponent's own girl had a fever in June and the Lath sat by her one night and said nothing at all and the girl mended, but this deponent will not say the Lath did it, and does not.

Hugh Ganlett, fisherman, aged fifty or more, saith: That coming up the bay by night in his shallop in the month of July he saw a woman go over the water toward the Great Salt Cove, high, and took it for a bird until it was not a bird. That it was the Lath. That all Providence knows of it and no man there will say so before a magistrate of the Bay. That he says it only because he lives at Pawtuxet and is under this government, and was asked.

Taken before me. [not signed]

II. To Hannah

Pawtuxet · the night of 22 September 1647

My dear Hannah,

I am well and the Pawtuxet business is near done. Arnold and his neighbors have had their say about the meadows and the Providence men have had theirs, and I have written it all down for the Court, which is what I was sent to do and the least of what has happened to me here, and that is why I am writing to you tonight and not tomorrow.

On Monday the Pawtuxet men brought me three persons to swear to a woman of Providence who goes in the air. I enclose what they swore, in my own hand. You will see I did not sign it. You will have heard by now about the woman hanged at Hartford in May, and you know the Providence men put witchcraft among the felonies in their own new code at Portsmouth the same month, so there is no place left in this country for such a woman to go. The Pawtuxet men knew all that. They are no friends to Providence and they wanted me to carry her back to Boston on a horse, and I could have done it. A magistrate of the Bay is a great man at Pawtuxet, Hannah. I had not known how great until I saw how they looked at my cloak.

Last night I went up to Providence to see the old man the witnesses named. It is five miles by the path. I took Tull the boy's father to show the way and four of the trained band with lanterns, because a magistrate does not walk anywhere alone, and I told myself it was to examine the old man. You will remember the name Simon Overy. He lectured at a parish in Essex and came over in the year we did, and preached once at Roxbury, and would not take a church afterward because, he said, he could find none that Christ had sent. So he keeps none. There are some at Providence of that mind, and they call themselves Seekers, and they meet at his fire on a weeknight and wait, and that is the whole of their worship. He fishes the cove for his bread. His house is at the foot of his lot on the shore, with the fire built outside it on the stones when the weather is fair.

I meant to put questions to him and I put none. He made room for me on his bench as if I had been expected, and my men stood back in the

dark with their lanterns, and he talked a little and then not at all. What he said I cannot rightly give you. That we are all waiting, the Bay too, only the Bay has built a house to wait in and is ashamed to say so. That waiting is not idleness, any more than a heron is idle. That I might wait with them if I liked, for it costs nothing. Then he was quiet, and the others were quiet, and the tide came in over the stones below us very softly, and Hannah, I sat on that bench without a word in my mouth until the first watch of the night was past, and I have not been so still since the winter we lost Mercy. I did not know there was anything left in me that could be still.

Then the woman came.

I will set it down as plainly as the boy did. She came out of the dark from the west side of the cove, over the salt water, at about the height of a ship's yard. She was not hurried. Her coat was all pieces, sacking and kersey and something that had been red, and the pieces moved in the air as she came. She came down onto the shingle at the very edge of the firelight, as light as you set down a cup, and stooped toward the old man the way a woman stoops coming into meeting late. And then she saw me. My men behind me with their lanterns. My band and my black broadcloth and the silver at my throat. She looked at me a moment, Hannah, the way you look at the window when it rains. Then she turned and went back up into the dark the way she had come, not hurried then either, and I heard the water under her and nothing else.

I asked him who that was, though I knew.

That is my daughter Thomasine, he said. *Of all of us here who wait, she goes first, and she goes in what the rest of us put off.*

He got up and went into the house and came back with a little book, not much bigger than my hand, and held it to the fire. It was Mr. Williams's book of the Indian tongue that was printed at London, and I had seen it at Boston and not read it, because of who wrote it. He turned to the place where Mr. Williams writes of the Indians' garments, and how they will pull off an English coat in the rain and go wet rather than spoil it, and then he read me the verses at the end of the chapter. I copied

them on the back of the Pawtuxet paper by his fire, and I copy them again here so you will have them.

> *Israell was naked, wearing clothes!*
> *The best clad English-man,*
> *Not cloth'd with Christ, more naked is*
> *Than naked Indian.*
>
> *— Roger Williams, A Key into the Language of America (1643), ch. XX*

And a line above it in the same chapter, of the Indians in their skins, that they creep into them contentedly, by day or night, in house or in the woods, and sleep soundly: *That every man be content with his skin.* He said, *She is content with hers. There is not much of it.*

Then he told me about the child, the same as the Pratley woman had told it but slower, and about the lots. Every lot on the Towne Street has its dead at the back of it, under the apple slips, because Providence has no church and so no churchyard, and each house buries its own. She went to every one with the boy on her hip. Every one, and the town not five years old. She came back to him without the boy, and he said she gave the gown away the next week and has not been inside a house since but to sit with the sick.

Hannah, I thought of you all the while he talked. You carried ours up and down the chamber three days, and would not let the midwife near, and I stood in the door with my hat in my hands like a man come about a debt. You have not been out to meeting in two winters. Her little coat and her shoes are in the chest at the foot of our bed. I am not telling you to do anything with them. I would not dare. I only want you to know that I saw a woman tonight who had gone all the way to the bottom of it, and come out so light that the air would carry her, and that when she saw me in my good clothes she was sorry for me, and turned back so as not to make me ashamed.

You may write what you came to write, he said, when I stood up. *She will not run. There is nowhere she would sooner be than on that rock by the falls.*

I have written nothing. I am sending you the informations so that you may burn them at our own fire, where I have sat. Or keep them. You will know which.

I left my cloak on the shingle where she came down. I did not give it. Overy said she would not take it if I gave it. I took it off and set it on the stones above the tide mark, and walked off up the lot and left it lying, the way a man leaves a thing he is done with. Tull's father thought me mad, and the trained band said nothing at all, all five miles back in the dark with the lanterns, and I was cold, and I did not mind it.

I will be home on Friday. Your loving husband,
N. H.

III. Endorsed

On the back of the informations, in another hand

Rec'd of my husband, the 27th of September. Not proceeded upon. Kept. H. H.

• • •

The paper stayed in a Dorchester chest for a long time, folded in four, under a child's linen cap with the strings cut off. Hannah Harrowe went out to meeting on the first Sabbath in October, and the women made room on the bench, and nobody said anything about it, and that was right.

Of the four men of the trained band, one of them, a Watertown man named Tobias Kember, sold his lot within the year and went to Providence and was a Seeker there the rest of his life, and never would say why, except that he had stood in the dark one night holding a lantern and found he did not need it.

In April, when the alewives came up the Moshassuck so thick that a boy could take them in his hands, Ephraim Tull went to the falls in the gray of the morning and found the Lath sitting on the flat rock below them, in a black broadcloth cloak gone green along the shoulders, with the silver clasp cut off and a patch of sacking let into the back where she

had given the good cloth away to somebody. The fish went up past her in the white water, all silver, all one way. She did not look at them, and she did not look at him, and the hem of the cloak lay in the river and was wet, and she let it.

Background

The verse

> *The man who wears dirty raiments, who is emaciated and covered with veins, who lives alone in the forest, and meditates, him I call indeed a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 395, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

One night Sakka, king of the gods, comes with his retinue to sit before the Buddha on Vulture's Peak and listen. The nun Kisā Gotamī, "Gotamī the thin," the same woman who once carried her dead son from house to house in search of medicine, comes through the air to pay her respects, sees the king of the gods, and turns back. Sakka asks who she is. The Buddha answers that she is his daughter, foremost among the nuns who wear robes sewn from cast-off rags, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Kisā Gotamī.

Providence Plantations, Rhode Island

Providence Plantations, 1647

Providence was founded in 1636 by Roger Williams, banished from Massachusetts Bay, and it filled up with other people the Bay had pushed out, among them supporters of the minister John Wheelwright in the Antinomian Controversy, whose petitioners were disarmed by order of the General Court in November 1637. Williams himself left the Baptist church he had helped to found and became a Seeker, one of those who held no church to be rightly gathered and met in silence to wait. Because

the town kept no established church, it kept no churchyard either, and for its first sixty years families buried their dead in their own plots; the town did not vote to lay out the North Burial Ground until 1700. Some of the settlers at Pawtuxet, a few miles south, quarreled with their Providence neighbors over land and in 1642 put themselves under the government of Massachusetts, which kept its claim there for sixteen years (William Arnold).

Williams wrote A Key into the Language of America on his first voyage to England, to secure a charter for the colony, and his friend Gregory Dexter printed it in London in 1643. It is a phrasebook of the Narragansett language, with Williams's observations of Narragansett life and a short poem at the end of each chapter that usually turns the comparison back against the English. In May 1647 the four towns met at Portsmouth under that charter and adopted a code of laws that listed witchcraft among its capital crimes; the same month, on May 26, Alse Young of Windsor was hanged at Hartford, the first recorded execution for witchcraft in the English colonies.

After the story of Kisā Gotamī from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 395). The original. Verses from Roger Williams, *A Key into the Language of America* (London, 1643). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.13

Hombre Sincero

Yo soy un hombre sincero
De donde crece la palma.
— Versos sencillos I

Así lo oí yo, on Calle Ocho.

I. The Palms

Little Havana, Miami, Florida · April 1980

On the wall of Octavio Iturralde's office on the ninth floor of a bank on Brickell Avenue there was one photograph, and everybody who came into the office was told about it whether they asked or not. It showed a road of red earth running straight away from the camera for a kilometer between two rows of royal palms, a hundred and twenty palms on each side, white-trunked and smooth and as tall as a six-story building, and at the far end of the road, small and white, a house with a portico. That was the Central Santa Rosalía, in the province of Matanzas. His great-great-grandfather had planted the palms. There had been Iturraldes in Matanzas since before the English took Havana. The house was a school now, he had heard. The palms were still standing. Nobody had told him so but he knew it, because a royal palm does not fall down for a revolution.

He was fifty-seven. He had left in 1960 with one suitcase, like everybody, and come back in April of 1961 with a rifle on the beach at Girón, like the best of them, and spent twenty months in Castro's prisons, and come home to Miami on Christmas Eve of 1962, when the Brigade was ransomed for fifty-three million dollars in food and medicine. He did not talk about the prison. He was a vice president now. He had a house in

Coral Gables with a mango tree, and a wife from a family as good as his, and a membership in the Big Five Club, which the exiles had founded so that the families of the Havana Yacht Club and the Vedado Tennis and the Biltmore and the Miramar and the Casino Español would have somewhere to dance at Christmas, as they had at home. He sent money every month to the widows of the Brigade. He was, as everybody said, a caballero.

On Saturday mornings he played dominoes in the little park on Calle Ocho, under the trees, at the concrete tables, with men who had been nobody in Cuba. He did not have to. His father had played on Saturday mornings in a park in Matanzas with the men who cut his cane, and called them by their names, and so Octavio did too. He played well. He slapped his tiles down hard on the concrete the way you are supposed to, and drank the little cups of black coffee the boy brought round on a tray, and at the Brigade dinner every April, when they all stood and sang, he sang the loudest of anybody, with his hand on his chest, the words every Cuban child learns before he can read.

Yo soy un hombre sincero, de donde crece la palma.

I am a sincere man, from where the palm grows. He meant it. His family had planted the palms.

II. Mariel

Mariel Harbor and the Florida Straits · May 1980

In the first week of April a bus crashed through the gate of the Peruvian embassy in Havana, and Castro took away the guards, and in two days ten thousand people were packed onto the embassy grounds, in the trees, on the roof, on the walls, and the government called them trash. Then on the twentieth of April Castro said that anyone in Miami who wanted their relatives could come and get them at the port of Mariel.

Miami went to sea. Men who had never been on a boat hired anything that floated, shrimpers and party boats and cabin cruisers and lobster boats from the Keys, and the captains charged a thousand dollars a head

and more, and the boats went south across the Straits by the hundreds, and the first of them came back into Key West on the twenty-first with forty-eight people aboard. Octavio had a cousin in Havana, Lourdes, his mother's sister's daughter, and her husband and two boys. He hired a shrimp boat out of Stock Island with a captain named Earl who spoke no Spanish, and in the second week of May he went himself.

They sat in Mariel harbor for nine days. There were a thousand boats at anchor, and the Cuban officials came out in launches and took the lists of names and went away again, and sold them ham sandwiches at five dollars apiece, and nobody knew anything. On the ninth day a launch came alongside in the afternoon with a soldier standing in the bow and a load of people sitting on the thwarts, and the soldier told Earl to take them, all of them, now, and go. There were thirty-eight. Lourdes was not among them. There were men with shaved heads from the prison at the Combinado del Este. There was a boy of nineteen who was gay and had been beaten, and said so, as if he were giving his address. There was a man in a hospital gown who sat in the bow the whole way across and sang. There was a woman with a baby. There was an old Black man in a pressed white guayabera with a cardboard suitcase tied up with string, and when Octavio helped him over the rail the suitcase was so heavy he almost dropped it, and the old man said it was books.

Octavio shouted at the soldier that these were not his people and the soldier put his hand on his pistol, and Earl said something in English that did not need translating and started the engine.

It blew up rough in the Straits after dark. The boat was built for twelve men and a hold full of shrimp, and it rolled, and everybody was sick, and the man in the hospital gown sang, and the woman held her baby inside her blouse to keep the spray off it, and the boy who had been beaten wept. Then the old man with the suitcase got it open, and took out a book, and found the place by the light of the wheelhouse, and began to read out loud. He had a voice that carried without being loud. It was *The Count of Monte Cristo*, in Spanish, the part where Dantès is in the Château d'If and hears the scratching in the wall. He read it to them for four hours, in the wind, standing braced in the door of the wheelhouse with

one hand on the frame, and nobody on that boat said anything until the lights of Key West came up out of the sea.

On the dock at the Truman Annex, in the floodlights, with the Immigration men and the Red Cross and the television cameras, the old man shook Earl's hand for a long time.

Gracias, hombre sincero.

Earl, who did not know what it meant, said you're welcome. The old man turned to Octavio and shook his hand too.

Gracias, señor.

Octavio gave him a twenty-dollar bill and his card from the bank and went home to Coral Gables and did not sleep. Lourdes came over in June, on a different boat, with nothing but her husband and her boys and the clothes they had on. He never did find out who had paid for it.

III. The Lector

Máximo Gómez Park · summer 1980

The old man's name was Cándido Valdés. Octavio found that out in July, in the park, when he looked up from his tiles on a Saturday morning and saw him on the bench under the trees with the *Diario Las Américas* open across his knees, reading it out loud.

He was reading the whole thing. The front page, the editorials, the box scores, the deaths. He read it the way he had read *Monte Cristo* on the boat, standing up inside his voice, every word given its weight, and the men at the tables nearest him had stopped playing to listen, and then the next tables had, and when he came to the end of an article somebody would say *otra*, another, and he would turn the page.

It came out over the summer, the way things come out in a park. He was seventy-three. He had been a lector for forty-one years at a cigar factory in Havana, which was a job that only existed in Cuba and in Tampa: you sat on a platform at the front of the big rolling room, above three hundred men and women at their benches, and read aloud to them all day while they rolled, newspapers in the morning and novels in the afternoon, and they paid you themselves out of their wages, so you read

what they voted for. Mostly they voted for Dumas. The rollers at one factory had loved *The Count of Monte Cristo* so much, the old men at the tables told each other, that the company had named a cigar for it.

He had no family. When he was asked his people he said he was a Valdés, and the Cubans at the tables understood, and the ones who were not Cuban had it explained to them. For two hundred years, any child left at the door of the Casa Cuna in Havana, the foundling home, was given the name of an old bishop of Havana who had looked after it. Valdés. It was the name for nobody's son. There were thousands of them. Everyone in Cuba knew a Valdés who was a Valdés for that reason, and nobody asked.

He had come over on the boatlift because the factory had a new lector, a young one from the Party, who read *Granma* in the morning and the speeches in the afternoon, and the rollers had stopped voting. He had spent his first six weeks in Miami in the tent city under the I-95 overpass at Seventh Street, at the foot of Little Havana, with the cars going over his head all night. Now he had a room on Eleventh Avenue, over a botánica, for sixty dollars a month, which a church paid.

The men at the tables took to bringing him the paper. Then they took to bringing him coffee, and pastelitos, and in August one of them brought him a pair of reading glasses from the drugstore, and he read them the news of the boatlift, which was still going on, and the news from Liberty City, where the Black neighborhoods had burned for three days in May after a jury in Tampa acquitted the policemen who had beaten a Black insurance man to death after stopping him on his motorcycle. He read that in the same voice as everything else. Nobody at the tables said anything about it. In the paper and on the radio, every day, men who had come over in 1960 and 1961 talked about the Marielitos, how they were not like us, how Castro had emptied his prisons and his madhouses onto the boats, how the city was ruined, and he read those too.

And Octavio, who played at the third table, noticed what everybody noticed, which was that the old lector had a way of naming people.

He called the boy who brought the coffee round on the tray *hombre sincero*. The boy was a Marielito, sixteen, who had come over on a shrimp boat alone and lived with a cousin in Hialeah and sent his tips home to his mother. He called the Haitian who sold mangoes from a shopping cart at the corner *hombre sincero*, in Spanish, and then in French, and the Haitian laughed and gave him a mango. He called the woman who swept the park in the mornings *mujer sincera*. He called Tito the boxer, who had fought in Havana before the revolution and had drunk himself out of a room on Flagler Street and now slept behind the dry cleaner's, *hombre sincero*, and Tito wept.

He did not call everybody that. Most people he called by their names. Some people he called señor. He called Octavio señor.

IV. The Question

The third table · a Saturday in September

It went on bothering Octavio all summer, and he could not have said why, and it bothered him more that he could not say why. He had pulled the man out of the sea. He had given him twenty dollars. His family had planted the palms in the song. If anybody under those trees was a sincere man from where the palm grows, it was an Iturralde of Matanzas. The old man knew the song as well as he did. He had heard him sing it.

On a Saturday in September, when the heat had begun to go out of the mornings, Octavio finished his game and stood up and went over to the bench where Cándido Valdés sat with the paper folded on his knee and the coffee boy's tray beside him, and sat down at the other end of it.

Maestro. He used the word the rollers would have used. *Can I ask you something?*

Ask.

You call that boy hombre sincero. You call the Haitian with the cart hombre sincero. You call Tito hombre sincero, and Tito sleeps in the alley. And you call me señor. He heard his own voice and did not like how it sounded and went on anyway. *My family has been in Cuba since before the English took*

Havana. My great-great-grandfather planted the palms in that song. I was born under them. I went back with a rifle. If that word belongs to anybody in this park it belongs to me. I'm asking you why you don't use it.

The tables near the bench had gone quiet. Somebody turned a tile over on the concrete, and the click was loud.

Cándido Valdés looked at him for a while. Then he reached down into his shopping bag, under the newspaper and the mango the Haitian had given him, and brought out a small book with no cover left on it, held together with a rubber band, and took the rubber band off, and turned the pages until he found the place, though everybody at the tables could see he did not need the book.

I don't know where I was born, he said. *Somebody put me down at the door of the Casa Cuna in the night, and the nuns picked me up in the morning and wrote Valdés. That's my palm. So I don't call a man by where he was born. I wouldn't know how. Martí didn't either. Listen.*

And he read it, standing up inside his voice the way he had in the door of the wheelhouse, a few lines from the piece Martí wrote in New York in 1893, when the Spanish were telling Cubans that a free Cuba would be a war of black against white.

> *Hombre es más que blanco, más que mulato, más que negro.*
>
> *Los hombres de pompa e interés se irán de un lado, blancos o negros; y los hombres generosos y desinteresados se irán de otro.*
>
> *— Martí, Mi raza*

A man is more than white, more than mulatto, more than black. The men of show and self-interest will go off to one side, white or black, and the generous men, the ones who want nothing for themselves, will go off to the other. Every man at the tables knew what it said. Some of them had learned it in school, in the old Cuba, and some in the new.

V. The Poor of the Earth

The same morning

That's the race, Cándido said. *The only one. The generous and the disinterested. It isn't born. Nobody is born into it. The boy with the coffee came over with nothing and sends his tips to his mother and keeps nothing. The Haitian gives me his mangoes. Tito has nothing left in this world to hold on to but his hands, and he gave me those, the day I came, to carry my suitcase.*

And me?

You, the old man said, not unkindly, *are holding on to a road with two hundred and forty palm trees on it, ninety miles away, that you will never walk on again. And a club for dancing. And a bank. And that word. With all that in your hands, what am I going to call you? You're a señor. It's not an insult. Señor is a fine word. It's what you call a man by what he has.*

Octavio said nothing.

You sing it every April, Cándido said. *Hombre sincero, de donde crece la palma. Everybody stops there. Nobody reads the rest of the book. The man who wrote that song had nothing. Not a peso. He lived in a rented room in New York and wrote for the newspapers and gave everything he had to the war and went home to fight it and was shot off his horse five weeks after he landed. That's who said hombre sincero. Listen to what he said he wanted.*

He turned a few pages back in the coverless book and read again, quieter this time, as if it were only for the man on the other end of the bench.

> *Con los pobres de la tierra*
> *Quiero yo mi suerte echar:*
> *El arroyo de la sierra*
> *Me complace más que el mar.*
>
> *— Martí, Versos sencillos III*

With the poor of the earth I want to cast my lot. The stream in the hills pleases me more than the sea. Octavio had known those lines since he was seven years old. Every child in Cuba knew them. He had never in his life heard them.

He sat on the bench. The tables around him had started playing again, quietly, out of courtesy, and the tiles clicked. The coffee boy came by with his tray and Octavio took a cup without looking at it, and paid, and the boy said *gracias, señor*, and went on.

Octavio thought about the photograph on his office wall. The red road and the palms. He saw it more clearly than he had seen it in twenty years, and he saw, for the first time, the men in the photograph, which he had looked at a thousand times and never seen: three of them, small, black, in straw hats, with machetes, at the foot of the palms on the left side of the road, where somebody had put them to give the picture its scale. Nobody knew their names. Nobody had written them on the back. They were somebody's sons. They could have been Valdés, every one of them. They had held nothing, and the palms had been theirs as much as anybody's, and they had come from everywhere and gone everywhere, and the road had gone on being a road.

Something that had been closed in Octavio Iturralde since the beach at Girón opened, a little, the way a fist does when you stop telling it to hold on. It did not feel like losing anything. It felt like setting down a suitcase he had been carrying so long he had stopped knowing it was heavy.

• • •

He did not give away the bank, or the house in Coral Gables. He did not resign from the Big Five. People who knew him only from the bank would not have said he had changed at all. But the photograph came down off the wall of the office on Brickell that fall and went into a drawer, and that winter, when the last of the Marielitos were still sitting in the camps at Fort Chaffee because nobody would sponsor them, the ones with no family and no papers and the wrong color, the hard-to-sponsor cases, Octavio sponsored eleven men, and went to Arkansas himself to get them, and found them rooms and found them work, and never told the Brigade dinner about it.

One of them was the man who had sung in the bow of Earl's boat in a hospital gown. Octavio found him a bed in a home in Allapattah, and visited him on Sundays, and the man sang to him.

VI. The Soup

Máximo Gómez Park · 1981

Cándido Valdés read the newspaper under the trees on Calle Ocho for six more years, until his eyes went, and then for two more after that from memory, Martí and Dumas and the Gospel of Saint Luke, which he said was the best-written thing in Spanish, though it was not Spanish. When he died, in 1988, the men at the tables took up a collection and buried him at Woodlawn, on Eighth Street, up the road from the park, and the stone they bought says CÁNDIDO VALDÉS, LECTOR, and nothing else, because nobody knew the year he was born.

But that was later. On a Saturday morning in the spring of 1981, a year after Mariel, Octavio came to the park with his newspaper under his arm and sat down at the third table, and the four of them turned the fifty-five tiles face down on the concrete and mixed them, which the Cubans call making the soup, all eight hands at once going round and round, the bone tiles clicking against each other with their black backs up, every one of them the same as every other from the back, so that you could not tell, until you drew it and turned it over in your hand, whether you were holding the double nine or the blank.

Octavio drew his ten without looking at them and stood them on their edges in a row. Across the park, on the bench, the old lector had the paper open on his knees and was reading the box scores out loud to anybody who wanted them, and the coffee boy was going round with the tray.

The boy stopped at the third table. Octavio took a cup and paid him and said, *Gracias, hombre sincero*, and the boy laughed, and said, *De nada, hombre sincero*, and went on.

On the bench, Cándido Valdés turned the page.

Background

The verse

> *I do not call a man a Brahmana because of his origin or of his mother. He is indeed arrogant, and he is wealthy: but the poor, who is free from all attachments, him I call indeed a Brahmana.*
>
> Dhammapada 396, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a brahmin notices that the Buddha calls his own disciples "brahmins." He reasons that since he was born of a brahmin mother, the Buddha ought to call him one too, and goes to ask. The Buddha answers that he does not call a man a brahmin because of the womb he was born from; a man who clings to possessions is only a *bhovādī*, one who goes about saying "sir," and only the one who has nothing and grasps at nothing does he call a brahmin. At the end of the teaching, the brahmin enters the stream. Here the title becomes *hombre sincero*, from the first line of Martí's *Versos sencillos*, and the "sir" becomes *señor*. Read the full commentary story. The poet is José Martí (1853–1895), whose lines from *Versos sencillos* (1891) became the words of "Guantanamera"; his essay "Mi raza" appeared in New York in 1893. The verses are quoted here in the original Spanish, which is in the public domain; the English in the story paraphrases them.

Little Havana, Miami, Florida

Miami, 1980

In April 1980, after some ten thousand Cubans crowded into the Peruvian embassy in Havana seeking asylum, Fidel Castro opened the port of Mariel to anyone who wanted to leave. Between April 15 and October 31, the Mariel boatlift brought about 125,000 Cubans to Florida, along with some 25,000 Haitians. Exiles hired whatever boats they could, and the Coast Guard reported that Cuban officials forced overloaded boats to take on passengers, sometimes at gunpoint, while boaters waiting in Mariel paid five dollars for a ham sandwich. Many of the newcomers were younger,

more working-class and darker-skinned than the exiles of the early 1960s, and some had come from prisons and mental hospitals. They were held at the Orange Bowl and in a tent city under I-95 at the foot of Little Havana, and the hardest to sponsor were sent to Fort Chaffee in Arkansas. Many of the earlier exiles belonged to families of the old Havana clubs, and in 1967 they founded the Big Five Club in Miami. In Cuba, children left at the Casa Cuna, the Havana foundling home, were given the surname Valdés, after Bishop Gerónimo Valdés, one of its early patrons.

Cándido's trade was that of the lector, hired by cigar workers in Cuba from 1865 on to read newspapers and novels aloud while they rolled; the Montecristo brand took its name from the novel the rollers loved. Octavio fought at the Bay of Pigs in April 1961; the captured men of Brigade 2506 were released in December 1962 in exchange for some $53 million in food and medicine. On Calle Ocho, Máximo Gómez Park, known as Domino Park, has drawn Cuban men to its tables since the early 1970s.

After the story of one brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 396). The original. Verses from José Martí, "Mi raza" (1893) and *Versos sencillos* (1891), in the original Spanish. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.14

Come Round Right

'Tis the gift to come down where we ought to be.
— Shaker song, "Simple Gifts" (1848)

This is how I had it, on the public square at Lebanon.

I. The Seats

Lebanon, Warren County, Ohio · June 1846

I WAS NOT BORN YET FOR ANY OF THE FIRST PART, SO I GIVE IT the way my mother gave it to me, and the way the town gave it to me later, which was not the same way, and I have tried to put the two together where they meet.

Varnell's Olympic Circus came up the pike from Cincinnati every June with four wagons, eleven horses, a round top of canvas, and a family of tumblers out of Lancashire who had been in the country since 1830 and still said *summat* and *nowt*. They played Lebanon two days at the end of Broadway, past the Golden Lamb, and the farmers came in from Turtle Creek and Deerfield and Mason and set the seat planks so full that the boys built their own seats on top of them, a bench on a bench on a barrel, swaying, and watched from up there under the canvas with their heads nearly in the smoke of the lamps.

My father, Asa Lindley, was up on one of those. He was twenty-two. His father had the dry-goods store on Broadway with the plate window and the bolts of Merrimack calico standing in it like organ pipes, and Asa clerked there and kept the ledger in a good round hand and was expected to have the store, and had never once in his life climbed anything higher than the ladder to the top shelf.

On the second night old Varnell set a mast in the middle of the ring, guyed to four stakes, and his daughter Kitty went up it barefoot. She was eighteen. At the top there was a wooden button no bigger than a dinner plate. She went over once in the air above it, came down standing on it, and then she sang. She sang *The Rose of Allandale* standing on that plate with her arms out, forty feet over the sawdust, and stepped off the button onto nothing and back onto it in time to the song, and the whole tent held its breath on every step. My father said afterward that it was her hands he saw. That she used her hands up there as if she were talking to somebody.

He went home and lay down on his bed with his boots on and turned his face to the wall.

If I can have her I'll live, he said. *If I can't I'll lie here till I die.*

He meant it, too. He would not eat. His mother sat on the bed and said there were girls in Lebanon with fathers who owned land, and good girls, and she named three. His father stood in the door and said the rest of what a dry-goods merchant says. On the fourth day my grandfather put a thousand dollars in gold eagles in a canvas bank bag and gave it to my father's friend Hiram Dill, who clerked at the bank, and said, *Take this down to that Englishman and tell him to send the girl up.*

Old Varnell was splicing a guy line on the tail of a wagon. He opened the bag and looked in it a long time, because it was more money than he had ever seen in one place, and then he tied it up again.

I'll not sell my lass, he said. *Not for that nor for twice that. But if it's true the lad can't live without her, let him come along with us and work. If he'll do that, he can have her.*

Hiram took that back up Broadway. My father got up off the bed. *Of course I'll go,* he said, and went to the washstand and washed his face. His mother cried and my grandfather swore and neither of them could stop him. He went down to the lot in the morning in his oldest coat with a carpetbag, and Varnell married them before a justice at Xenia on the way to Springfield, with two tumblers and a horse for witnesses.

II. Hush

The road · 1846–1849

They played Xenia and Springfield and Urbana and Bellefontaine, and went down through Dayton and Hamilton to the river, and over into Indiana at Madison and Kentucky at Maysville, and wintered in Cincinnati in a livery barn on Sycamore Street where Varnell kept the horses fat and the family thin. They played wherever a town would let them have a lot and a license, and left in the night where it would not.

My father drove the property wagon. Wherever they stopped he watered eleven horses at whatever creek or town pump there was, and cut grass for them with a scythe if the farmer would let him, and he dug the holes and set the poles and stretched the canvas and drove the stakes, and when it was over he pulled the stakes and folded the canvas and loaded the poles and drove on. He had never done a day's outdoor work in his life. His hands bled a month and then went to horn. The tumblers called him the Clerk.

I was born in March of 1847 in the livery barn on Sycamore Street, in the harness room, with the horses talking the whole time through the wall. They called me William for my mother's father, and the tumblers called me the Clerk's Boy.

My mother went back up the mast in April. In the evenings after the show she sat on the wagon step with me on her knee and jogged me and sang, and what she sang she made up as she went, to whatever tune was handy. My father was greasing a wheel. He heard it three nights.

Hush, the water-boy's baby,
hush, the stake-driver's son,
son of a man who don't know a flip from a fall,
hush, now, hush.

Is that me in the song?

Aye, it's you.

Then I'll go off and leave you.

Go or stay, she said. *What's it to me?* And she sang it again, and I laughed, my mother told me, I laughed every time.

I do not hold it against her. I have been in the business sixty years and I know what she was. She was the best thing on a mast between Pittsburgh and St. Louis, and every man on every seat in every town looked up at her as if she were the evening star, and she brought in more on a good night than the rest of the family together. She did not need him for anything. She had not asked him to come.

He sat on the wagon tongue a long while in the dark that night, he told a man years later, thinking. Why is she so proud? Because of what she can do up there. Well, then.

In the morning he went to old Varnell. Varnell looked at him, and looked at his hands, and nodded.

Hush, the stake-driver's baby,
hush, now, hush.

He was the better part of two years learning. He learned the tumbling first, on a strip of carpet in the barn on Sycamore Street, all that winter, the flip-flap and the round-off and the back somerset, and fell on his neck more times than anyone could count. In the spring he learned the mast, on a twelve-foot pole and then a twenty and then the forty. He fell off it at Chillicothe into a pile of straw Varnell had told the boys to put there, and at Portsmouth into the river, which was not on purpose. He learned to go up hand over hand and turn on the button and come down standing on it, and then to stand up there in a wind, which is the whole of it, Varnell said: anyone can turn, it's the standing after.

My mother watched him from the wagon step with me on her knee and did not sing the song anymore. But she did not say anything else either.

Hush.

III. Handbill

Lebanon · July 1849

The cholera came up the river to Cincinnati again that summer, worse than in thirty-two, and the city buried more than a hundred some days in July, and anybody who could get out got out, up the pikes into the country, and some of them carried it with them. It was at Franklin and at Waynesville. In Lebanon the Western Star kept telling the town it was free of it, which meant everybody in town was afraid of it. The President had appointed the first Friday in August a day of fasting, humiliation and prayer across the whole country on account of the pestilence, and the churches on Broadway were getting ready.

Varnell would not play the river towns that year. He brought the show up the pike to Lebanon at the end of July, and my father went to the printer at the Star office with three dollars and came out with this, which I have, which my mother kept in her trunk until she died and which is in front of me now with the folds worn through.

Seven Days Hence!

ON THE PUBLIC SQUARE, AT LEBANON,

on Saturday the Fourth of August, at Three O'Clock,

MR. ASA LINDLEY,

Son of a Merchant of this Town, lately with Varnell's Olympic Circus,

Will Ascend the

HICKORY POLE

and Perform Upon the Top Thereof

Feats of Equilibrium and Lofty Tumbling Never Before Attempted at Such a Height.

No Charge. The Public is Respectfully Invited.

The hickory pole stood at the crossing of Broadway and Main. The Democrats of the town had raised it for General Cass the summer before, a hundred and ten feet of shagbark hickory in two pieces, scarfed and banded with iron, out of the Little Miami bottoms, and when Cass lost in November nobody had the heart to take it down, and nobody had the money either. The flag was in tatters on top of it. My father went up it on the Monday at five in the morning when there was nobody on Broadway

but a milk wagon, and took the flag down, and nailed a pine plate onto the top of it the size of the button on Varnell's mast.

My grandfather tore the handbill off the door of the store with his own hand. My grandmother read it at the upstairs window and sent down a cold chicken in a basket by the hired girl.

IV. The Hickory Pole

The public square · Saturday, 4 August 1849

THE TOWN HAD FASTED ON THE FRIDAY, OR SAID IT HAD, AND on the Saturday it came to the square. They came in from all the townships, in spite of the cholera or because of it. They backed hay wagons into the square in a ring and set benches up in the wagon beds and chairs on the benches, and stood on the chairs, and sat on the roof of the market house and in the windows of the Golden Lamb and up in the elms. Somebody said three thousand. My mother sat in the bed of a hay wagon by the Star office with me on her knee. I was two years and five months. I believe I remember the elms, but I am not sure.

My father went up the hickory pole at a quarter after three in a scarlet jacket all over spangles that had been Varnell's, and white tights, and bare feet. He went up the way she had gone up the mast in 1846, hand over hand, and the square went quiet under him the way a church does. Above the iron bands he went slower. At the top he got his knee on the plate, then a foot, then the other foot, and he stood up a hundred and ten feet over Broadway and let go of the pole with both hands.

He could see the whole county from there, he said afterward. The Miami bottoms and the hills toward Waynesville. The roof of the store, with the skylight his father had put in for the calico. The steeples. Turtle Creek going off northwest through the woods, and a long way out along it, the big brick and white frame dwellings of the Shakers at Union Village standing in their fields like a town with nobody in it, because on a Saturday the Shakers were all at work.

He lifted one arm for the noise, and they gave it to him. Then he went over once, all the way round in the air, and came down standing on the plate.

The square came up off its chairs. He said it was like standing on the top of a sound. He stood in it, a hundred and ten feet up, and turned to take a bow to the four corners, and saw it go out of them all at once like the wind going out of a sail.

They were not looking at him.

Down the Turtle Creek road and into Broadway, at a walk, came the Union Village wagon. It was a long blue box wagon with two gray horses, loaded with crates of bottles, and on the seat and walking beside it were six Shakers, three brethren in their broad hats and gray coats with their hair cut straight across the brow, and three sisters in their caps and kerchiefs and long plain gowns. They were bringing the town their extracts and their herbs for the cholera, as they did every summer, to the druggist on Main. They did not look up at the pole. They did not look at anything. They came along Broadway at the pace of the horses with their hands folded, the way they walked everywhere, and the whole square turned on its chairs to watch them come, the way it had turned to the pole. Nobody could have told you why. People had seen Shakers all their lives.

The oldest of them walked at the near horse's head. She was a small woman of seventy with a face like a winter apple, and her name was Eldress Hepzibah Rawle, and she had come to Union Village from New Lebanon in New York before my father was born, and taught the Shaker girls their letters and the Shaker boys how to dry a seed, and kept the family's accounts in a hand you could have printed from. When the wagon came into the square she stopped it with one hand on the bridle, under the pole, and the brethren and sisters stopped behind her, and three thousand people looked at her.

My father stood on the plate in his spangles with nobody looking at him.

He told a man years afterward that it was the worst thing that ever happened to him. Worse than the song. He said: a year and a half it took me to learn that turn, and in the middle of it six people walk into town

selling medicine and it's gone. He said he stood up there and thought about stepping off the plate. Not falling. Stepping, the way Kitty used to step off the button onto the air, only not coming back.

The eldress looked up. She was the only one in the square looking up just then. She said something over her shoulder to the biggest of the brethren, a man named Amos Tiller who had been a keelboatman on the Ohio before he came to the Shakers and could lift a hogshead of molasses off a wagon by himself. He went and stood at the foot of the hickory pole with his broad hat pushed back, and put his head back, and called up, with a keelboatman's voice.

Asa Lindley! Eldress wants to see thee turn! Turn for the people, she says. Make them laugh!

The square turned back around on its chairs.

My father, a hundred and ten feet over Broadway, felt his heart come up in him like a bucket out of a well. She wanted to see it. He put his hands on his knees and leaned out and called down.

Brother! Tell her watch close! Tell her I'll turn for her and for all of them!

And he jumped.

I give it the way the town gives it, because I have heard it from forty people and they all say the same and none of them could have been lying, they were too many. He went up off the plate into the air higher than he had any right to go, so high that people on the market-house roof ducked, and he turned over. And over. And over. Fourteen times, the town says. Old Dr. Scofield, who watched from his window, wrote fourteen in his diary that night, and that he had counted them aloud. And he came down out of the last one onto the pine plate on the top of the hickory pole as soft as a cat onto a fence rail, and stood, and was still.

Nobody made a sound. Then they made all the sound there was.

When it was over, and only then, the eldress spoke. She did not raise her voice. She did not have to. People who were on Main Street that day, a block off, swear they heard her as plain as if she had been at their elbow. She said it up the pole as if he were standing next to her.

Asa. Let go of what's behind thee. Let go of what's ahead of thee. Let go of the plate under thy feet. When thy hands are empty all the way down, thee needn't ever come up here again.

Then the six of them sang, standing in the square by the gray horses, a short song with a dance in it, though they did not dance, and that was the first time anybody in Lebanon ever heard it. It had come out from the Shakers in Maine the year before, copied from family to family in the little hymn books they kept.

'Tis the gift to be simple, 'tis the gift to be free
'Tis the gift to come down where we ought to be,
And when we find ourselves in the place just right,
'Twill be in the valley of love and delight.

When true simplicity is gain'd,
To bow and to bend we shan't be asham'd,
To turn, turn will be our delight,
Till by turning, turning we come 'round right.

— Shaker song, "Simple Gifts," attributed to Joseph Brackett (1848)

Three thousand people stood still and listened to six Shakers sing, and some of them said afterward it was the strangest five minutes they ever spent, and some said they could not remember a thing about it but the tune, and some went home and did not drink again, and a good many of them, years later, when they told about the fourteen turns, would put the song in without knowing they did it, humming it under the telling.

My father stood on the top of the pole and heard it. I asked him once, the only time I ever saw him again, what happened to him up there, and he thought a long while, and said: *Nothing happened, Will. Something stopped.*

Then he came down. Hand under hand, slow, not hurrying, past the iron bands and the scarf joint and the old Cass bunting nailed halfway, and stepped off onto Broadway in his bare feet, and the people who were close to the pole stepped back from him.

His hair was white.

It had been brown that morning, brown as mine, and he was twenty-five years old, and he came down off the pole with his hair as white as the eldress's cap, and the lines in his face of a man of sixty, and his hands were an old man's hands. He walked across Broadway to the gray horses and went down on his knees in the dust in his spangles in front of a woman of seventy in a plain gown.

Take me, he said. *If you'll have me.*

Come, then, said Eldress Hepzibah. *Get up out of the road.*

He got up and took off Varnell's jacket and folded it and handed it up to my mother in the hay wagon, and she took it. He put his hand on my head. And he walked away down Broadway behind the blue wagon in his white tights and bare feet, alongside Amos Tiller, toward the druggist's and Turtle Creek and Union Village, and the square watched him go, and so did she, and so did I.

My mother did not cry, that day or after. She sat in the hay wagon with the spangled jacket in her lap until the square was empty, and then she got down and carried me back to the lot.

V. Day Book

Union Village · August 1849

THE SHAKERS KEPT A JOURNAL AT EVERY FAMILY, A LINE OR two a day, weather and work and who came and who went. In 1912, when I went to the sale, a brother of the last few let me sit in the office and copy out what the Center Family book said for that August. I give it as it was written.

> **Sat. 4th.** Very warm. Eldress H., Brother Amos and four others to Lebanon with the extracts. Returned near dark, and brought with them a young man of the town, Asa Lindley, son of the merchant, who had been with a show. He wishes to try the life. His hair entirely white, though he gives his age as 25.

> **Sun. 5th.** Meeting. A.L. present on the brethren's side. Was asked by some of the young brethren after meeting whether he was not afraid coming down off of the pole, it being above 100 feet. He says, Nay, he had no fear at all. Some of the young brethren think this is not the truth, seeing what has happened to his hair, and say that it is a show-man's brag and he must labor to overcome it.

> **Mon. 6th.** Hot. Cutting oats. A.L. in the broom shop. Brother Seth spoke to Eldress H. about A.L. saying he had no fear, that he thought it a lie and not fit for a Believer.

> **Tues. 7th.** Eldress H. spoke in the evening meeting concerning A.L. and fear. Said: When a man has let go every rope he had hold of, there is nothing left in him to shake. It was not fear that turned his hair; it was the letting go. Brother Seth is not to say again that A.L. lies. Then we labored the new song from the East, and A.L. labored it with us, and did very well at the turning.

> **Wed. 8th.** Rain at last. Thanks be. Two of the young brethren and A.L. at the brooms.

That is all there is about it. On the ninth they started the buckwheat.

VI. The Sale

Union Village · 1912

My mother went back up the mast in September of 1849 and stayed up it nine more years, until her knees went, and she never sang that song to me again. She kept the spangled jacket in her trunk and wore it once more, to be buried in, at Cincinnati in 1866. I was on the road by then with the big shows, Spalding's and afterward others, and I have been on it ever since, a leaper and then a rider and then thirty-one years an equestrian director, and I have seen every kind of turn there is and a good many people come down off a good many things. I never saw anybody else come down the way he did.

I saw him once. I was fourteen, and the war had started, and I walked out from Lebanon along Turtle Creek without telling anybody and asked at the office for Brother Asa. They let me sit with him in the broom shop for an hour. He had a broom-corn vise and a winding wheel, and he wound brooms the whole time I was there and talked to me, and his hair was white, and he was the happiest man I have ever sat with in my life before or since, and I was very angry, and he let me be. When I got up to go he said, *Will, does thy mother still sing?* and I said not that song, and he said, *That's a shame. It was a good song.*

He died at Union Village in 1897. In 1912 the last of the Shakers there sold the whole of it, four thousand acres and the dwellings and the mills, to the United Brethren for a home for orphans and old people, and I went out for the auction of the movable goods, which I had no business doing at sixty-five, and bought one lot, which was a broom-corn vise and a winding wheel from the broom shop, for a dollar and a quarter.

The old brother who let me copy the book walked out to the wagon with me. He had known my father forty years. I asked him whether there was anything else he could tell me, anything at all, and he stood a while with his hand on the wheel.

He said: *He used to sing at the brooms. All day, under his breath, winding. The same little song. A lullaby, it sounded like. I asked him once what it was and he laughed, and said it was a hymn somebody made up about him, and that it was the truest one he knew.*

I have the wheel in the barn. When I turn it, which I do some evenings, it goes round with a little tick at the top of every turn where the iron is worn, and I wind nothing on it, and I sing.

Hush, the stake-driver's baby,
son of a man who don't know a flip from a fall,
hush, now, hush.

Background

The verses

> *Give up what is before, give up what is behind, give up what is in the middle, when thou goest to the other shore of existence; if thy mind is altogether free, thou wilt not again enter into birth and decay.*
>
> Dhammapada 348, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has cut all fetters, who never trembles, is independent and unshackled.*
>
> Dhammapada 397, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

A rich man's son, Uggasena, falls in love with an acrobat's daughter he sees dancing on the top of a pole, and lies down to die unless he can have her. Her father will not sell her, but gives her to him if he will travel with the troupe. Uggasena drives the carts and fetches grass and water and sets up the apparatus, and when his wife sings to their baby about the son of a cart-driver and a know-nothing, he learns the acrobat's art himself and comes home to perform on a sixty-cubit pole. At the height of his act the crowd turns to look at the Buddha entering the city. The Buddha sends Moggallāna to ask him to perform; Uggasena turns fourteen somersaults, hears the Buddha's verse on the top of the pole, and is freed. He comes down, is ordained, and instantly takes on the look of an elder of sixty. When the monks doubt his claim that he felt no fear coming down, the Buddha confirms it with a second verse. Read the full commentary story (the same story is told at Dhp-a 24.6).

Lebanon, Ohio

Lebanon and Union Village, 1849

Union Village, founded in 1805 in Turtlecreek Township near Lebanon, was the first and largest community of the United Society of Believers in Christ's Second Appearing, the Shakers, west of the Alleghenies. It had more than 600 members by 1818,

and its families lived by farming, broom making, garden seeds, and medicinal herbs and extracts. The Shakers lived celibate, held goods in common, and worshiped in song and ordered dance; men and women converts left marriages behind when they joined. "Simple Gifts," a dancing song generally attributed to Elder Joseph Brackett of the Maine Shakers, dates from 1848. In 1912 the remaining Shakers sold Union Village to the United Brethren in Christ, who opened a children's home there in 1913; the grounds are now a retirement community.

In the 1840s American political parties raised tall campaign poles in town squares: Democrats raised hickory, for Andrew Jackson, "Old Hickory," and Whigs raised ash, for Henry Clay's Ashland (a Springfield, Illinois, marker records a 150-foot Democratic hickory pole there in 1844). In 1849 cholera killed roughly 6,000 people in Cincinnati, about one in twenty, and spread into the surrounding towns; Lebanon's Western Star of July 27, 1849 reported deaths in Franklin and Waynesville while declaring Lebanon itself free of the disease. On July 3, 1849, President Zachary Taylor proclaimed the first Friday in August a national day of "Fasting, Humiliation, and Prayer" on account of the pestilence.

After the story of Uggasena from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 348 and 397). The original. Song from the Shaker "Simple Gifts" (1848). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.15

Tow Strap

Unclamp, in a word, your intellectual and practical machinery, and let it run free.
— William James, "The Gospel of Relaxation" (1899)

This is the way we heard it, on the association beach at Lake Ellery.

I. Entry

Lake Ellery, Commerce Township, Oakland County, Michigan · Monday, June 16, 1986, 6:48 a.m.

ADULT BEGINNERS, SESSION ONE. SKILL: ENTER THE WATER safely and stand.

There were eleven of us, and none of us could swim, and all of us lived within a mile of the water. That was the thing nobody on the lake knew, or if they knew they were nice about it. We had moved out from Royal Oak and Livonia and Redford and the east side, some of us in 1971 and some last fall, for the schools and for the lake, and we had docks, and pontoon boats some of us, and children who swam like otters, and for years we had sat on the end of the dock in a folding chair with our feet out of the water and said we did not care for it much.

The Lake Ellery Property Owners Association put a notice in the spring newsletter, between the reminder about lawn fertilizer and the minutes of the April meeting, that Mrs. Wachowski would give a two-week course for adult beginners at the association beach, seven to eight in the morning, Red Cross method, free to members, and that the class would be *confidential*. Somebody on the board had underlined that word. Eleven of us called her. Two of us called her twice, to back out, and she said she would see us Monday.

So that Monday we came down the path from Heron Point Drive at a quarter to seven, one at a time, in robes and in T-shirts over our suits, trying not to see each other, and found each other anyway. Carol Dempsey, who taught third grade in the Walled Lake schools. Ray Fenner, a quality supervisor at Pontiac Motor, sixty-one, who had been in the Navy in Korea and had never told anybody on the ship. The two Hallorans, Pat and Marie, who were doing it together because they had a grandson coming in August. A dental hygienist named Linda. A Lutheran pastor's wife. A man who sold insurance and a man who sold boats, which was the funniest thing about the eleven of us and the thing none of us mentioned. Janet Lusk, from the yellow colonial on the point, who had watched a cousin go under at Kensington when she was nine. Two others. And me, or we, whichever of us is telling it; we decided later we would tell it together, since we were all there.

The association beach is forty yards of trucked-in sand between the boat launch and the swimming dock, with a lifeguard chair nobody sits in before Memorial Day and a split-rail fence around it. On the Friday before, the association's contractor had dumped twenty yards of new beach sand in a pile in the parking lot for the volunteers to spread, the way they did every June, and nobody had spread it yet.

Gary Lusk and Dennis Sorensen were standing on top of the pile.

II. Bobbing

6:52 a.m.

SKILL: HOLD THE BREATH AND PUT THE FACE IN THE WATER. Come up. Do it again.

Everybody on the lake knew about Gary and Dennis. They were both engineers at Ford, both in Truck Operations at Dearborn, both forty-four, both from Livonia, both on the association board, and they lived next door to each other on the point, and for two years they had been arguing about trucks.

Gary had been on the full-size Bronco since 1979, the big one, built on the F-150 frame at the Michigan Truck Plant in Wayne, with the 351 V-8.

Dennis had been on the Bronco II since before it had a name, the little one off the Ranger, built down at Louisville, with the new fuel-injected 2.9 V-6 that came in this year. Each of them drove the one he worked on. Both trucks were tan, two-tone, tan over darker tan, and they sat side by side in the two driveways on the point like a cow and her calf, and the children on the lake called them Big Tan and Little Tan, and so did everybody else eventually, and so, by the end, did Gary and Dennis.

The argument had started at the Fourth of July picnic in 1984 over which one would pull a pontoon trailer up the launch, and it had gone on through two Christmases and an Easter brunch and the April board meeting, where it had to be ruled out of order. Dennis said weight was nothing, it was gearing and traction, and a short wheelbase on soft ground was worth a hundred pounds of torque. Gary said a V-8 was a V-8. Their wives had stopped going to things together. Janet Lusk had told one of us in March that she lay awake some nights listening to the two of them at it across the side yards, low, in the dark, like dogs at a fence.

That morning, it turned out, they had met at the pile by accident, each of them come down early to start spreading sand before work as a favor to the board, each with his own truck and his own utility trailer and his own shovel, and each had looked at the other and seen what was going to happen.

All right, Gary said. We heard him from the dock. *All right. We'll settle it.*

They took Gary's trailer, an eight-foot steel one, and backed it down the launch ramp and off the side of the concrete into the soft sand at the edge of the water, where the beach goes wet and dark. Then they shoveled it full from the pile, both of them, in their work slacks and good shirts, without a word, a wheelbarrow at a time, until the springs were flat and the tires had gone into the wet sand to the rims. Then they unhitched it. The idea, as near as we could tell, was that whoever could pull it out of there and up onto the ramp would win.

We were in the water by then, the eleven of us, standing in a row up to our waists along the swimming-dock rope, holding the rope with both hands. Mrs. Wachowski had told us on the phone to get in and get used

to it if we came early. Nobody had told us to put our faces in. We stood there holding the rope with our chins up and watched.

Dennis went first. He hooked a nylon tow strap from the Bronco II's hitch to the trailer tongue, a yellow one, two inches wide, still in its plastic bag from Kmart. He got in and put it in four-wheel low and took up the slack and gave it gas. The little truck dug. All four wheels threw sand. The trailer did not move one inch. He gave it more, and the engine went up high and thin, and the tires went down into the beach, and Gary stood with his arms crossed, and then the strap went.

It went with a crack like a .22, and the free end came back and hit the Bronco II's tailgate and left a stripe in the tan paint you could still see in September.

Gary laughed. That was the worst thing that happened that morning, maybe. It was not a nice laugh. Dennis got out and looked at his tailgate and did not say anything.

Then Gary hooked up Big Tan, with his own strap, a heavier one, red, and a pair of shackles. He did not go easy. He backed up to get a run at it, and hit the end of the strap at maybe ten miles an hour, and the big truck jerked and the trailer jerked and rocked and settled back down into the wet sand deeper than before, and Gary backed up and hit it again, and again, and on the fourth time the hitch ball on the trailer tongue tore loose of its nut and the strap and the shackle came whipping back over the sand and took out a post of the split-rail fence.

Then both of them were standing in the sand with nothing in their hands, yelling.

We will not put down what they said. Some of it was about trucks and some of it was about Ford, which they both loved, and some of it was not about either, it was about the side yard and the property line and something at a Christmas party, and some of it was about a man's wife, and Janet Lusk was standing in the lake beside us holding the rope.

The trailer sat where it was with its wheels in the beach and its load of sand on it, exactly where they had put it, and had never moved.

III. Front Float

7:01 *a.m.*

SKILL: TAKE A BREATH, PUT THE FACE IN, LET THE LEGS COME up. Five seconds. Recover to a stand.

Mrs. Wachowski came down the path at seven exactly, as she always would, every morning of those two weeks, with a canvas bag over her shoulder and a whistle on a shoelace around her neck. She was sixty-eight. She had taught girls' physical education at Pontiac Central for thirty-four years and given Red Cross swimming lessons every summer since 1946, at Elizabeth Lake and Cass Lake and Sylvan and the Pontiac Y, and she had taught, she said once, something over four thousand people to float, and she was proudest of the ones who were over forty.

By then Gary and Dennis had both driven off to Dearborn, separately, and the beach was empty except for the trailer and the strap and the post lying on its side.

She looked at all of it. She looked at us in our row holding the rope. She put her bag down on the lifeguard chair and took off her sandals and walked into the water in her suit to her waist, and stood in front of us.

Well, she said. *What happened here?*

So we told her. All of us at once, and then one at a time. Big Tan and Little Tan. The two straps. The hitch ball. The fence. Somebody started to say what they had yelled, and she held up her hand.

She did not say anything for a while. She looked at the trailer.

Those are tow straps, she said. *Anybody can break a tow strap. You saw two men do it before seven o'clock in the morning without even trying. That's not what you came down here for.* She put her hand flat on the water in front of her and pressed down on it, a little. *You came down here to break the other kind. The one that's been holding you up on the end of the dock for forty years. The one that wants to win, and the one that's scared. It's the same strap, mostly. Those two this morning had the first kind wound so tight around them they couldn't move a trailer of sand.*

Then she went back to the lifeguard chair and got a paperback out of her canvas bag, an old clothbound copy with a cracked spine and a coffee

ring on the cover, and came back into the water with it held up out of the wet, and read to us. She said it was William James, the psychologist, who gave these talks to schoolteachers in Cambridge, Massachusetts, in the eighteen-nineties, and that somebody had given her the book in 1952 at a phys-ed conference in Lansing and she had been reading it to beginners ever since, because a man who could write that well about not trying so hard was worth listening to.

> *If we only check a cowardly impulse in time, for example, or if we only don't strike the blow or rip out with the complaining or insulting word that we shall regret as long as we live, our feelings themselves will presently be the calmer and better, with no particular guidance from us on their own account.*
>
> *— William James, "The Gospel of Relaxation," Talks to Teachers on Psychology (1899)*

Now, she said, and put the book back on the chair. *Breathe in. Faces in. I've got you.*

IV. Back Float

7:20 a.m.

SKILL: LIE BACK ON THE WATER WITH THE EARS UNDER. ARMS out. Let it hold you.

It took the whole hour, and we did not all get it that first day. But we will say what happened, because it is the reason we tell this.

She took us one at a time, with her hand flat under the small of the back. Lie back. Ears in. Look at the sky. She said the same thing to every one of us, in the same voice, not loud. She said the water would hold us up if we would let it, and that the only thing in the lake that could sink us was the part of us that was holding on. She said a line from the book without looking at it, as if it were a line from a song she had sung so often it had worn smooth, that a person who never gives himself up wholly to the chair he sits in, but keeps his muscles half contracted for a rise,

cannot be anything but anxious. *Give yourself up to the chair,* she said. *This is the chair.* And she took her hand away.

Ray Fenner went first. He lay back stiff as a plank and sank and came up coughing and lay back again, and the second time something went out of his shoulders and he floated, sixty-one years old, with his eyes wide open, looking at the sky over Commerce Township, and he started to laugh, and the laughing did not sink him.

Then the Hallorans, together, holding hands, which she allowed. Then Carol. Then the boat salesman. Then the pastor's wife, who prayed out loud the first time and not the second. One after another, along the rope, the eleven of us lay back on Lake Ellery, and it held us.

Janet Lusk was last. She stood a long while with her hands on the rope, looking at the trailer up on the beach with her husband's red strap still shackled to it, and at the post on its side, and Mrs. Wachowski waited and did not hurry her and did not say anything at all. Then Janet let go of the rope. She lay back. Her hair went out around her head on the water. Mrs. Wachowski took her hand away, and Janet floated, and her face did something none of us had seen it do in two years on the point, and she did not cry, but it was close.

We lay there, all of us, with our ears under, so that the whole world was the sound of our own breathing and the far small knock of somebody's outboard on the other side of the lake, and the sky over us was white and then blue, and none of us was holding on to anything.

• • •

That evening, about six, some of us were out on our docks and saw Gary and Dennis come down to the association beach, separately, a few minutes apart, each in old clothes with a shovel. They did not say anything we could hear. They shoveled the sand off the trailer and spread it on the beach, a wheelbarrow at a time, both of them, until the trailer was empty and the beach was new, and then they each took a side of the tongue and walked it up out of the wet sand onto the ramp by hand, which it turns out you can do with a trailer if there is nothing in it, and Dennis held the light while Gary put the ball back on. Then Gary picked

up the post and set it back in its hole and tamped it with his heel, and they went home up the path to the point, one ahead and one behind.

The yellow strap lay in the sand by the lifeguard chair in two pieces all that summer. Nobody threw it away. By August the frayed ends had gone white in the sun, and the children used one piece to mark the finish line for races in the shallows, and the other piece somebody tied to the swimming-dock rope, about where the eleven of us had stood, and it floated there on the water every morning at seven, and it held nothing, and the waves lifted it and set it down.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has cut the strap and the thong, the chain with all that pertains to it, who has burst the bar, and is awakened.*
>
> Dhammapada 398, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Two brahmins, one with an ox called Little Tawny and the other with an ox called Big Tawny, argue over whose ox is the stronger. Tired of arguing, they load a cart with sand on the bank of the Aciravatī river and yoke the oxen to it. Some monks come down to bathe and watch: the brahmins whip the oxen, the cart does not stir an inch, and the straps and thongs break. The monks tell the Buddha, who says that anyone can cut those outward straps; a monk must cut the inner strap of anger and the thong of craving. Hearing the verse, the five hundred monks are freed. Read the full commentary story.

Commerce Township, Oakland County, Michigan

Oakland County, 1986

Oakland County, north and west of Detroit, is dotted with hundreds of small glacial lakes, and after the Second World War the townships around them filled with subdivisions of commuters to the auto companies, many of them organized into lake and property-owner associations with private beaches. In 1986 Ford built two Broncos. The full-size Bronco, in its third generation (1980–1986) based on the F-150, came from the Michigan Truck Plant in Wayne, Michigan, and could be had with a 5.8-liter V-8. The compact Bronco II, derived from the Ranger pickup and built alongside it at the Louisville Assembly Plant in Kentucky, was sold from the 1984 model year; for 1986 it got a fuel-injected 2.9-liter V-6.

William James delivered his Talks to Teachers on Psychology to schoolteachers in Cambridge and elsewhere in the 1890s and published them in 1899 with three talks to students, among them "The Gospel of Relaxation." There he argues that American "over-tension" is a habit, that feeling follows action as much as action follows feeling, and that a person who never gives up wholly to the chair they sit in cannot be at rest. The American Red Cross, which hired Wilbert E. Longfellow in 1914 to organize its volunteer life-saving corps and went on to build a national water-safety program, taught most of the country's twentieth-century learn-to-swim classes, adults among them, through local volunteer instructors like Mrs. Wachowski.

After the story of the two brahmins from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 398). The original. Words from William James, "The Gospel of Relaxation," in *Talks to Teachers on Psychology* (1899). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.16

Even So

> *If they were pushed, struck, or thrown down, they rose again and went away; but no complaint was found in their mouth.*
> *— John Wesley's Journal, as quoted in The Great Controversy*

I heard it told this way, in the Cove below Graysville.

I. Delphia

The Bratcher place, Rhea County, Tennessee · June 1895

I WILL TELL MY PART FIRST BECAUSE IT IS THE SMALLEST AND it is where it started.

I sneeze in threes. I always have, from a girl. My mother said it was the pepper in our blood. And I am a stumbler. I catch my toe on nothing, on the edge of a rag rug, on the shadow of a door, and Absalom used to say I could fall down a well that was not there. And from the spring of 1893, when I first sat under Brother Swafford's reading in Ma Kelso's front room and came out of it knowing the seventh day, whenever I sneezed or tripped or coughed so it hurt, what came out of my mouth was *Even so, come, Lord Jesus.* I did not decide it. It came out of me the way the sneeze did.

Absalom was a Methodist local preacher, and his father was, and his grandfather rode a circuit out of Knoxville when it was Indian country. All four of the Bratcher boys could preach, and three of them did. It was a preaching family, and they were known for it from Washington to Smith's Crossroads. I married into it at seventeen.

Every quarter when the presiding elder came for quarterly meeting, the preachers ate at our house. It was the custom. I killed four hens and a rooster and made the dumplings and the stack cake the day before, and

fourteen men sat down in their black coats with their hats on the bed, and the presiding elder asked the blessing, and I carried in the platter.

I caught my toe on the doorsill. I did not drop the platter. I want that known. But I said it, loud, the way you would say it if you saw Him in the yard. *Even so, come, Lord Jesus.*

Nobody said anything. The presiding elder took a thigh. And Absalom sat at the head of his own table among his own kind with his face going red from the collar up, and I knew by the time the stack cake came that he would not keep it.

He kept it until they had gone. Then he said that he had married a woman who could not trip over a thread without hollering for the Adventist's Jesus, as if there were two, and that it was that old man Swafford had done it to her, and that old Swafford was at that hour breaking rock on the county road in chains for plowing on the Lord's day and that was where he belonged, and that he, Absalom, would go up there tomorrow and take him apart on the Scriptures in front of the guard and the whole gang, and then we would see.

I said, *Go on, then.* I said, *I have never yet seen the man that could best him. But you go and ask him something.*

II. Absalom

The rock pile at the bridge approach, near Spring City · the next morning

I AM THE OLDEST. I WILL TRY TO SAY IT STRAIGHT.

There had been Sabbath-keepers in the Cove for twenty years and nobody minded them much until they built their school at Graysville and got a store, and then somebody minded. A man swore out a warrant on Silas Swafford for plowing his bottom on a Sunday in April. There were others charged, for fodder pulling and for carrying boards and for helping dig a well. The judge fined them and said he did not much like the law himself but it was the law. Not one of them would pay a cent of it. Paying, they said, would be keeping Sunday. So they lay in the jail at Dayton. Then the court got the chain gang up again for them, that had

not been used in years, and in July they hauled them up the valley in two wagons and set them to breaking rock for the approaches of a bridge.

I had preached against them. I had preached against them by name.

It was hot already at seven. There was a guard on a stump with a shotgun across his knees, a Tallent boy I had baptized. There were nine men in that line with hammers, and a pile of blue limestone higher than a barn, and a pile of broken rock beside it the size of a corncrib, and the sound of it. If you have not heard nine hammers on limestone you do not know what I mean. It is not a din. They were keeping time.

Swafford was at the end. He was seventy-one that year. He had been a sawyer and he had the arms still. He had a rag around his head for the sweat and the chain on his right ankle had rubbed through his sock. He looked up and saw me and set the hammer head down on the rock and leaned on the helve and waited.

I did not say good morning. I had a question ready. I had worked on it half the night. I thought I would catch him between the commandments: he would say a Christian must kill nothing, and I would ask him about the Amalekites, or he would name a thing, and I would ask him where the Book said so. I said, *Swafford, you are a Bible man. Tell me this. Is there one thing on God's earth you say a Christian is bound to kill? And what does a man have to cut off to sleep easy at night?*

He thought about it. He looked at the rock.

The same thing both times, he said. *Cut off your temper and you'll sleep. Cut it off and you won't grieve. That's the one thing I know of you're bound to kill.*

I opened my mouth and he went on.

You know spotted cowbane, that grows in the wet places down along the creek? The children dig it sometimes. They say it's sweet. It is sweet. Tastes like a parsnip, they say, and then it kills them. That's what temper is. It's sweet in your mouth at the first. You were tasting it all the way up here, Brother Bratcher. I saw you coming up the road with your mouth working.

Then he picked up the hammer.

I stood there. The Tallent boy looked at me and looked off. I had not been able to sleep for a year, if I am honest, not since she started saying

it, and I had thought it was her. I stood there until the sun was over the pile, and then I sat down on the broken rock and listened to them keep time, and I do not know how long. When I came home Delphia was in the garden. I sat down on the chopping block and said she had better tell me about the seventh day from the beginning, and she did, and she sneezed three times telling it.

I kept my first Sabbath on the third of August. They indicted me at the next term. I would not pay either.

III. Wash

The same place · August 1895

I WAS THE LAWYER OF US. I HAD READ LAW AT CLEVELAND AND I was acting for the state that term because the attorney general was down with his kidneys. It was my office indicted my own brother. I want that understood. I did it in the regular course.

When I heard Ab had gone over to them I went up to the rock pile on a Sunday afternoon, when they were not working because the law would not let them, which is a joke I did not see at the time. They were sitting in the shade of the log house where the gang slept. I said what I came to say. I said it to Swafford. I will not write it all down. I called him an old fool and a Jew and a disturber of the peace of a Christian county and a stealer of wives and of brothers, and some other things, and I am a lawyer and know how to say a thing so it goes in. I went on a good while. The others got up and went inside. He did not. He sat on the step with his hands between his knees and heard every word as if I were reading him a deed.

When I had run down he said, *Wash, when the quarterly meeting comes to your house, does Lou set the table?*

I said what did that have to do with it.

She kills her hens and makes her stack cake and sets it all out for them?

I said she did.

And say they came in, and looked at it, and wouldn't eat. Got up from the table and went home and never touched it. Whose dinner is that?

I said, *Why, it's ours. We'd eat it.*

That's right, he said. *Well. You've set a big table here this afternoon. I thank you for it. I'm not going to eat any. You carry it on home.*

That was all he said. I stood there in the yard of that log house with the whole of it in my arms, everything I had said, and it was heavy. And it was mine. He was right, it was mine. I had been cooking it a long time.

I did not prosecute the September term. I wrote to Nashville that I was unwell, which was true. I kept my first Sabbath in October.

IV. Pretty and Clabber

The same place · September 1895

Our names are Sunderland and Thomas, but nobody has called us that since we were in dresses. I am Pretty and I taught singing school, the round notes and the shape notes both, and I am vain, I know it. My brother is Clabber because he was a sour baby and has been a sour man, and he runs the sorghum mill. He cannot write, so I am writing for both of us, and he says to put down that he does not agree with how I tell it.

We went up together the second Sunday in September because there was nobody left to go. Our father was dead. Ab was keeping Saturday. Wash was keeping Saturday. Our mother had not left her bed in a week. Clabber said somebody had to whip that old man and he would hold my coat.

I am not going to tell what we said because it was worse than Wash, and Clabber says that is the only part I have right.

I will tell this. While I was saying it, Swafford was looking at me the way you look at a horse you are thinking of buying, all over, without any hurry. And when I was done he said, *You've got a good voice, Sunderland. Your mother always said so.* And he said to Clabber, *How's the cane this year, Tom?* And Clabber, who had come to whip him, told him how the cane was, for a quarter of an hour, the rust on the lower leaves and the price of a gallon at Dayton, and then sat down on the step beside him and told him the rest.

I cannot account for it better than that. We were the last two, and we had the least reason, and we came over the easiest. Clabber says that is because there was nobody left to be ashamed in front of.

V. The Time Book

The log house below Graysville · October 1895

THIS LAST PART IS MINE AGAIN, DELPHIA'S, BECAUSE I WAS there and none of them can tell it.

By October there were four Bratchers on the county's books, Ab and Wash on the gang, Pretty and Clabber bound over, and the gang was moved down the valley to a log house a mile and a half from Graysville with bars on the windows and the front door left open at night, because where would they go. On the Sabbath we women carried dinner up. The Tallent boy ate with us. He had not been made to and he did it.

After dinner the men sat on the floor of the big room, and it came up, the way it does when men are full, how it had been. One of the Graysville men said it was a wonderful thing. Four brothers, he said, and every one of them came up that road to curse him, and every one of them went home ours. And not one hard word back. Not a word in his own defense. He just stood there like a post and let them hang their coats on him.

Brother Swafford was by the door with the light behind him. He said it was nothing to do with him. He said, *I can't take credit for a thing I didn't do. I didn't do anything.* Then he said if they wanted to hear about not answering back they ought to hear about it from Ab's side of the family, and he got out his *Great Controversy*, which he had read through in the Dayton jail and then started again, and found the place, and handed it to Absalom, and Absalom read it. It was out of Mr. Wesley's own journal, the founder of his own church, about the Germans on the ship coming over.

> *Of their humility they had given a continual proof, by performing those servile offices for the other passengers which none of the English would undertake; for which they desired and would receive no pay, saying it was good for their proud hearts, and their loving Saviour had done more for them. And every day had given them occasion of showing a meekness which no injury could move. If they were pushed, struck, or thrown down, they rose again and went away; but no complaint was found in their mouth.*
>
> *— John Wesley's Journal, as quoted in Ellen G. White, The Great Controversy*

Absalom stopped reading there, though there was more. He had read it before. He had read it from a pulpit, in Spring City, in a sermon against the Adventists. He held the book open on his knee and did not say anything, and nobody else did.

Brother Swafford said, *A man that won't fight has got more soldiers than he knows.* And he looked around that room, at the four of them and the Graysville men and the women and the guard with the shotgun on his knees, and smiled, and that was the most I ever heard him say about it.

• • •

Later that fall I saw the Tallent boy's time book, because he left it on the table. It was a ruled book from the store at Dayton with the men's names down the side and the days across the top, and a mark in each square for a day served. Under every Saturday, all the way across, for every name, the squares were empty. That was the bargain: they would not work on the Sabbath, and the Sabbath would not count as time served, so that every man of them stood one more day in the chain for every Sabbath he kept. I looked down the page for one of them that had complained of it. The boy said I would not find one, and I did not.

I still sneeze in threes. I still catch my toe. I am seventy now and have been to the camp meeting at Graysville forty-nine times, and last summer I went down in the aisle of the big tent over a tent rope, all the way down,

in front of everybody, and I heard it come out of me, the way it always has, loud. And I heard four old men behind me, all at once, say it back.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who, though he has committed no offence, endures reproach, bonds, and stripes, who has endurance for his force, and strength for his army.*
>
> Dhammapada 399, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Dhanañjanī, a Brahmin's wife and a follower of the Buddha, cries out in praise of him whenever she sneezes or stumbles, and one day does it while serving a meal to Brahmins. Her furious husband goes to defeat the Buddha with a riddle (what must one kill to live at ease?) and is answered: anger, "a poisonous root, sweet at the beginning." He becomes a monk. His younger brother, the Insolent Bhāradvāja, comes to abuse the Buddha and is asked whether, when guests refuse the food he sets out, it is not still his own; so too the abuse the Buddha refuses. Two more brothers come to revile him and are won the same way, and when the monks marvel that he became their refuge without a word in reply, he speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story; the exchanges are in the Saṃyutta Nikāya (SN 7.1, 7.2 and 7.4). The teacher reads from *The Great Controversy* by Ellen G. White, which quotes John Wesley's journal of his 1736 voyage to Georgia with a company of Moravians.

Rhea County, Tennessee

Rhea County, Tennessee, 1895

Tennessee law forbade ordinary work on Sunday, and in the late 1880s and 1890s it was turned against Seventh-day Adventists, who kept Saturday and worked on Sunday. Around the Adventist school at Graysville, in Rhea County, members were

charged in 1894 and 1895 for such things as stripping fodder, carrying boards and helping dig a well. At Dayton in March 1895 Judge J. G. Parks said he doubted the justice of the law but enforced it; the defendants refused on conscience to pay even small fines and went to jail instead.

After a second round of convictions that summer, the county revived its chain gang, and in July 1895 Adventist prisoners were carried north in wagons to break rock for the approaches of a bridge near Spring City, later lodging in a barred log house near Graysville. Their guard agreed not to work them on Saturday, and not to count Saturdays against their sentences. Adventist papers such as the *American Sentinel* carried the story nationally, and many secular newspapers took the prisoners' side. Swafford, the Bratchers and the Tallent boy are invented.

After the story of the Insolent Bhāradvāja and his brothers from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 399). The original. Scripture from John Wesley's Journal as quoted in Ellen G. White's The Great Controversy (1888; 1911 edition). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.17

The Paper Ladle

What Matter was to Fragrance sweet is turned—
The cleansing fire its purity restores.
— Zabel Yesayan, "Incense"

Aysbes lsetsi, below Mount Auburn Street.

I. The Blessing

Dexter Avenue, East Watertown, Massachusetts · the Tuesday after Easter, April 1934

THE TRAY WAS ON THE DINING TABLE UNDER THE GOOD CLOTH: a glass of water, a saucer of salt, a slice of the Easter choreg. Hripsime Garabedian had set it out at six in the morning and then sat in the parlor in her black dress with her hands in her lap for five hours, and when the bell rang she let it ring twice before she got up.

He was on the step in his black robe and his pointed hood, with the censer in his hand and the little case of wafers under his arm, and behind him on the walk were the four altar boys from the new church on Mount Auburn Street, and her grandson Arto was one of them, with his hair wet down. Her son kissed her hand. She let him.

Come in, Father, she said. *Sit. You must be tired. How many houses is it today? Twenty? Thirty? Sit down.*

He began the prayers standing. She did not sit down either.
He lit the charcoal from the box of matches she handed him, and put the grains on it, and the smoke went up.

Thirty houses. And in every one a cup of coffee and a piece of somebody's choreg and a spoon of somebody's harissa and a quarter in your hand at the door, and you say thank you, Digin, God bless your table, and you go next door and do it again. I have seen you. Mrs. Kasparian on Arlington Street saw you on

Sunday scraping the bottom of her pot. Scraping it. She said the Vartabed is very humble, he would not let her open a new jar. I said yes, he is very humble.
He blessed the water. He made the cross over it three times.

Do you remember the harissa in Kharpert? Your father's mother made it in the copper pot with the lid that had a bird on the handle, and the whole street came, and you were so small you sat in the pot after, and licked the ladle, the back of the ladle, and your grandfather laughed until he had to hold the wall. I carried that ladle out. Did you know that? I carried it to Aleppo inside my dress. I carried it to Marseille. It is in that drawer. Everything else I left on the road and I carried a ladle, and you, and your sister. And now you go up and down Dexter Avenue licking the backs of other women's ladles.
He blessed the salt.

Your father had the shop on Boylston Street when he died. You know what we had. You know I bought these two houses with the rugs your father and I washed by hand in the cellar on Nichols Avenue. The shop was yours. Mr. Hovsepian would have taught you the books. You could have married any girl from here to Worcester. You had the shop and the houses and your father's name, and you went to Jerusalem and lay down on your face on a stone floor and gave them your name too, and came back with this one, which is not a name, which is a saint's name off a calendar. Arsen. Who is Arsen? My son is Krikor.
He blessed the bread, and set the wafer on it, stamped with a cross and grapes and wheat.

Khrimian Hayrik said that at Berlin there was a great pot of harissa on the table, and the Bulgarians and the Serbs came in with iron ladles and took their share, and the Armenians came with a ladle made of paper, and it went soft in the pot and they came home with nothing. Your father made us learn that. Everybody's father made them learn that. So here is my son. Fifteen hundred thousand dead, and they burned Kharpert, and I walked to Aleppo with my feet tied up in my own hair, and when we get to America and I make him an iron ladle with my two hands, he goes and makes himself one out of paper. You have ruined me. Do you know that? You have ruined me, Krikor. Sit down. Eat.

He sat down at her table. She brought the harissa in the blue bowl and he ate it, all of it, with the spoon she gave him, slowly, and did not say anything.

Then she turned to the boys standing against the wall with the candles.

And you. You are the ones who made my son your errand boy. You walk behind him and swing his smoke and eat on his account in every house in East Watertown. Sit. Eat. God made men and women; who made monks? Sit down, I said.

They sat. She fed them. She fed her grandson last, and gave him the biggest bowl, and pinched his ear so hard it was red the rest of the day.

When they had eaten, her son stood and finished the prayers, and blessed the house and every room of it, and her, and asked God to keep it from enemies seen and unseen, and gave her the wafer. He kissed her hand again at the door. She let him. Then he went down the steps to the Kasparians' and the boys went after him, and Hripsime stood at the window behind the lace and watched the smoke go away along Dexter Avenue, a little at every door, until she could not see it.

II. Questions and Answers

The Sahag Mesrob school, the church hall on Mount Auburn Street · Saturday

ARTO BROUGHT VARJOUHI A PIECE OF HIS GRANDMOTHER'S choreg wrapped in wax paper, as he had been told to, and set it on her desk and asked her to eat.

Her name was Mrs. Takouhi Kalfayan, but nobody under fifty in the parish called her anything but Varjouhi, which only means teacher. She had come from Van. She had taught the alphabet in that city in the year the city was besieged, and in Erivan the year after, to orphans, in a tent, and now she taught it on Saturday mornings in the new hall on Mount Auburn Street to the children of rubber workers from Hood's, who would rather have been playing ball. She was very small. She had a way of asking you something as if the answer had been yours from the beginning and she only wanted to hear you say it. She broke off a piece of the choreg and ate it and asked him questions the way they did in the old catechism, and he answered the way the catechism answers.

Where were you on Tuesday?

On the house blessings, Varjouhi. With Hayr Surp.

To whose houses did you go?

To the houses on Dexter Avenue. To my grandmother's.

And what did your grandmother say to Hayr Surp?

She said he was a beggar. She said he licks other women's ladles.

What else?

She said things. This and that.

And what did Hayr Surp answer her?

Nothing, Varjouhi.

Nothing?

He ate the harissa. He said nothing.

She nodded, and finished her piece of choreg, and folded up the wax paper and put it in the drawer of her desk, and sent him back to his letters.

III. Incense

The church hall · the same afternoon

The story had gone through the parish by then. The hall had only opened that winter, and the heat had only just been put in, and the men who had carried the boxes of hymnals in from the truck were still sitting at the long tables in the afternoon with coffee, and the altar boys were stacking chairs, and the women were in the kitchen, and all of them were talking about it.

It was a wonderful thing, the men said. You know her, Hripsime Garabedian. You know her tongue. She said it all, in front of the boys, in front of God and the censer. And he did not raise his eyes. Not one word, not to his own mother. A man of thirty, and a priest. He sat and ate his harissa. What other man in this parish could do that? Mardiros said he himself would have thrown the bowl. Hagop said his own mother would have thrown it first.

Varjouhi was at the end of the table with her coat on, waiting for her ride. Somebody asked her what she thought.

She said that she did not think it was so wonderful. She said that a man has to have something lit in him to catch fire when it is thrown, and

that a man who has let all of that burn up already has nothing left in him for it to catch on. She said it is not that he is holding his temper. It is that there is no more temper. It went up. And she said, in Armenian, four lines about the incense from a poem by a woman of Scutari that she had taught to older girls in Van before the war, and the women in the kitchen door stopped talking to hear it.

> *Consumed within the censer now, and burned,*
> *The incense through the boundless ether soars.*
> *What Matter was to Fragrance sweet is turned—*
> *The cleansing fire its purity restores.*
>
> *— Zabel Yesayan, "Incense"*

He has finished, she said. *He is not coming back again as anything. That is the last of him, and it is very sweet. His mother is not finished, God keep her. Somebody should go and sit with her.*

Then her ride came, and she went out.

• • •

Hripsime Garabedian lived to be ninety-one and never once in her life said a kind word about the priesthood in anybody's hearing. But it is known in the family, because Arto's mother saw it, that on the night of the blessing she took the wafer her son had left on the tray and laid it in the flour jar, the way her own mother had done in Kharpert, and opened the drawer by the stove, and took out the old copper ladle with the bird on the handle, and pressed the flour smooth over it with the back of the ladle, and stood a long time in the kitchen with the ladle in her hand.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who is free from anger, dutiful, virtuous, without appetite, who is subdued, and has received his last body.*
>
> Dhammapada 400, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Sāriputta, the Buddha's chief disciple, comes on his alms round with five hundred monks to his mother's house in his home village. She, a Brahmin woman who never forgave him for leaving a great fortune, seats him and feeds him while abusing him as an "eater of leavings" who licks the backs of strangers' ladles, and abuses the monks for making her son their page-boy. He eats and goes back without a word. Rāhula, the young novice, reports it to the Buddha in a short exchange of questions and answers; when the monks marvel at Sāriputta's calm, the Buddha says that those whose taints are gone do not grow angry, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta. The teacher's poem is by Zabel Yesayan (Essayan), born in Scutari (Üsküdar) in 1878, quoted in Zabelle C. Boyajian's translation from *Armenian Legends and Poems* (1916). The grandmother's proverb about monks is from the Armenian proverbs in the anthology *Armenian Literature* (1904).

Watertown, Massachusetts

Watertown, 1934

Survivors of the Armenian genocide of 1915–1923, many of them from Kharpert (Harput) and the provinces of the east, built one of the largest Armenian communities in America in Watertown, a trolley suburb on the Charles just west of Cambridge, where many found work at the Hood Rubber Company. Factory workers began raising money door to door in 1926 for an Armenian Apostolic church on Mount Auburn Street. Services were first held in the new building in June 1933; the heating and the church hall were finished in 1934, and the parish had already taken over the Sahag Mesrob Armenian school.

In the Armenian Church's home blessing (*Tnorhnek*), given in the seasons after Christmas and Easter, a priest visits each household, blesses bread, water and salt set out on a tray, burns incense, prays for the family and leaves a wafer stamped with a cross. Armenian celibate priests, who may become vardapets and bishops, take a new name at ordination. The ladle in the story comes from a sermon of Mkrtich Khrimian ("Hayrik") after the Congress of Berlin in 1878: other nations took their share of the harissa pot with iron ladles, while the Armenian petition was a paper ladle that went soft in it. The Garabedians, Varjouhi and the priest are invented.

After the story of the Elder Sāriputta and his mother from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 400). The original. Scripture from Zabel Yesayan's "Incense," tr. Zabelle C. Boyajian (1916). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.18

The Seed on the Needle

> *I must behave myself like unto the lotus flower whose purity is not defiled by the mud.*
> *— Sutra of Forty-two Sections 29*

Iwa gachi naneun deureotda, off Route 29.

I. Red

Fairfax, Virginia · August 2018

Lee Ha-eun watched the fourth rally on her phone in the kitchen of her apartment, with the sound low because her roommate was asleep. It was Saturday afternoon in Seoul and two in the morning in Fairfax. Seventy thousand women sat on the pavement outside Hyehwa Station in a heat wave, nearly all of them in red, holding signs. One of the signs said MY LIFE IS NOT YOUR PORN. Another said OUR RAGE IS HOTTER THAN THE HEAT WAVE. They were chanting about hidden cameras, in toilets and changing rooms and motel rooms, and about the police, who did not find the men who put them there.

Ha-eun was twenty-six and in her second year of a social work degree at George Mason. She had a red T-shirt on. She had put it on when she got up to watch, without thinking, and then had thought about it.

She was sixteen the fall her uncle died. In her mother's house the story was that Jang-ho samchon had been killed in an accident in the country, on a farm road in the rain, and that the nun from the Centreville temple had something to do with it, and that it was not to be talked about. Her mother had not set foot in a temple since. Ha-eun had found out the rest at nineteen, from a girl at a church retreat who had seen the emails, and

she had gone home and sat in her car in the driveway for an hour and not gone in.

That August she was helping two friends put together a zine about the rallies for the Korean American students' group, with interviews. One of the friends, Grace Paik, said what about the nun.

She won't talk to us, Ha-eun said. *Why would she talk to us? I'm his niece.*

Then she'll talk to you, Grace said.

II. The Townhouse

Centreville · the same month

THE TOWNHOUSE WAS AN END UNIT OFF ROUTE 29, WITH A square of yard, a bus stop at the corner, and a candle in the front window that was not lit in the daytime. Two nuns lived there that year, Cheongryeon and a younger one who was at the temple. Cheongryeon opened the door herself. She was forty-six, in summer grays, with her head new-shaved and a gardening glove on one hand.

She listened to Ha-eun say who she was, standing on the step with the two friends behind her and her face hot. Then she took off the glove and said come in, it's too hot out here.

She made barley tea and set it on the low table and sat on a cushion. Ha-eun had written out what she wanted to say and did not look at the paper. She said she was sorry. For her uncle, for her family, for her mother, for the ten years nobody had said it.

Thank you, Cheongryeon said. *That's kind of you. It isn't yours.*

Grace had the recorder on. She asked whether Sunim had seen the rallies. Cheongryeon had. She said the young women in Seoul were right, and that the police there should listen to them, and the police here.

Are you angry? Grace asked.

Cheongryeon thought about it. *I was, a little, for a day. At the deputy. He didn't know where to look.*

Not at him. At the man who did it.

He's dead, she said.

The other friend, Min, who was studying to be a therapist, asked carefully whether she ever thought about it. In the shower, say. Whether it came back.

Sometimes I remember the light fixture, Cheongryeon said. *The way you remember a street you used to live on.*

Min asked one more thing, and blushed while she asked it, because her own mother went to that temple. Whether Sunim still felt things, the ordinary things. Whether she had ever wanted anybody. Whether she still did.

Cheongryeon did not blush. *Things come up,* she said. *They don't stay.*

III. The Argument

Fairfax · that night

They argued about it until one in the morning at Ha-eun's kitchen table, with the recorder off and a bag of shrimp chips going soft.

Min said it was dissociation. She said it kindly. It was the textbook picture, she said: the flat calm, the street-you-used-to-live-on, the not being angry at a man who did that to you. People survived by stepping out of themselves, and some of them never stepped back in, and a temple was the perfect place to never step back in, because everybody would call it holiness.

Grace said maybe it was the opposite, that she was performing it. That a nun had to be calm in front of the congregation the way a pastor's wife had to smile, and they had sat there and gotten the performance.

Ha-eun's roommate's boyfriend, who had come out of the bedroom for water and stayed, said with respect he didn't buy any of it. She was a human being. She wasn't a stone Buddha in a garden. Human beings had bodies, they wanted things, they got angry, they liked things, and anybody who said they didn't was either lying or broken. *Things come up, they don't stay,* he said. *Come on. Everything stays.*

Ha-eun didn't say anything. She was thinking about the candle in the window, and the gardening glove, and how Sunim had said it isn't yours, and whether that was true.

IV. The Needle

Annandale · September 2018

The old cook from the Centreville temple was ninety that year and lived with her son's family in a split-level off Ravensworth Road. She had stopped cooking at the temple at eighty-five, when her knees went, and now she sat in a chair by the window of the family room with a sewing basket and a jade plant and mended everything the family owned whether it needed mending or not. Ha-eun's grandmother had known her in the old days. It took two phone calls to get invited.

The cook was sewing a button onto her great-grandson's school shirt when Ha-eun came in. On the windowsill was a jar of small round brown seeds that her son had saved from the gat he grew along the fence, the bitter red-leafed mustard for kimchi, to plant again in the spring.

Ha-eun told her everything. Min's word, and Grace's, and the boyfriend's. She said she did not know which of them was right and she did not know why it mattered to her so much, except that it did.

The cook bit off the thread. She did not answer for so long that Ha-eun thought she had not heard.

Then she unscrewed the jar and took out one seed between her thumb and finger, and held the needle up point first, and set the seed on the point. It sat there for half a second. Then it rolled off and went down into the carpet, and was gone.

She did it again with another seed. It went off the other side.

Did the needle throw it? she said.

Ha-eun said no.

Did the needle hold on?

No.

Is there anything wrong with the needle?

Ha-eun laughed, because she was close to crying. *No, Halmeoni.*

The seed comes, the cook said. *The needle doesn't push it. The needle doesn't hold it. It doesn't stay, because there's no place on a needle for it to stay.* She threaded the needle again, squinting, and found a second loose button. *The boy is right, she's not a stone. Put a seed on a stone, it sits there till it rots. That's a stone.*

She sewed for a while.

There's a sutra, she said. *The nuns read it at night where I cooked. It tells the monks how to look at a woman. Like their mother, like their sister. Like the lotus.* She said the line in Korean, the way she had heard it every night for thirty years, and Ha-eun looked it up afterward on her phone in the car, in an English translation from 1906, and found that it said what the cook had said.

> *I am now a homeless mendicant. In the world of sin, I must behave myself like unto the lotus flower whose purity is not defiled by the mud.*
>
> *— Sutra of Forty-two Sections 29*

They wrote it for the monks, the cook said. *The monks needed it. She didn't need it written down.*

When Ha-eun left, the cook was bent over the carpet with her hand flat, feeling for the seeds. She found one. The other she did not find.

• • •

The zine came out in October with an interview that was mostly about the police. In March the cook's daughter-in-law, watering the jade plant by the sewing chair, found a mustard seedling coming up at the edge of its pot, two round leaves and then a third with a jagged edge, already going red at the rim. She left it there. Nobody in that house pulled anything up.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who does not cling to pleasures, like water on a lotus leaf, like a mustard seed on the point of a needle.*
>
> Dhammapada 401, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

This short commentary story is a second telling of the episode in 5.10, after the nun Uppalavaṇṇā has been assaulted. Some of the monks talk it over among themselves: the awakened are not dry trees or anthills, they say, but beings of flesh and blood, so surely they too still take pleasure in the senses. The Buddha answers that they do not. Pleasures do not cling to such a person, any more than water clings to a lotus leaf or a mustard seed stays on the point of an awl, and he speaks the verse. Here the nun is the same woman as in Honey on the Knife, ten years on, and, as there, the violation is secret filming rather than assault. Read the full commentary story, or about Uppalavaṇṇā.

Centreville and Annandale, Virginia

Seoul and Northern Virginia, 2018

In 2018 hidden-camera crime, called *molka* in Korean, became the subject of the largest women's protests in South Korean history. Beginning in May, women gathered every few weeks near Hyehwa Station in Seoul, most of them dressed in red, under signs reading "My Life Is Not Your Porn." The August 4 rally, held in a heat wave, drew about 70,000 people; one sign read "Our Rage Is Hotter Than The Heat Wave." South Korean police recorded some 6,800 reports of spycam crimes that year.

Northern Virginia's Korean community is centered in Annandale, in Fairfax County. *Gat*, the Korean leaf mustard used for a pungent kimchi, is a form of brown mustard (*Brassica juncea*), whose small round seeds are the mustard seed of the kitchen. The

cook's line is from the Sutra of Forty-two Sections, traditionally the first Buddhist sutra translated into Chinese, in D. T. Suzuki's English (1906). All the people in the story are fictional.

After the story of Uppalavaṇṇā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 401). The original. Scripture from the Sutra of Forty-two Sections, tr. D. T. Suzuki, in Soyen Shaku, *Sermons of a Buddhist Abbot* (1906). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.19

These Presents

> *I who had been a slave in the morning, trembling at the will of another, was become my own master, and completely free.*
> *— Olaudah Equiano, The Interesting Narrative, ch. VII (1789)*

This is how I heard it, at the Deep Creek lock.

I. Ran Away

Near the Great Bridge, Norfolk County, Virginia · January 1801

> TEN DOLLARS REWARD.
>
> RAN AWAY from the subscriber, or rather did not return to him at Christmas from his hire, a Negro man named JEM, about twenty-eight years of age, five feet nine or ten inches high, stout made, with a white scar across the back of his left hand got from a froe. He has been hired these three years past to the getting of shingles in the Dismal Swamp and is well acquainted therein. He is a professor of religion, a member of the Baptist society, sings well, and can say over a good deal from books though he cannot read. It is supposed he is lurking about the Swamp. Whoever takes up the said fellow and secures him so that I get him again shall have the above reward.
> EZEKIEL HODGES.

Elder Ezekiel Hodges wrote it out three times at the kitchen table before he was satisfied, and each time he struck the words *a member of the Baptist society* and each time he wrote them in again. They were true. He had put Jem under the water of the Northwest River himself, in the spring of 1797, with the ice just off the banks, and Jem had come up out of it gasping and laughing with his arms thrown wide, and the people on

the bank had sung him out. It did not seem to Hodges a thing a man ought to leave out of a description.

He was fifty-two that winter. He had preached thirty years without a license and without a salary, and as a young man, before the laws changed, he had spent two months in a county jail for it, preaching to whoever would stand in the road outside the window. He kept a farm of a hundred and sixty acres on the edge of the swamp, and six people to work it, and of the six Jem was the strongest, and so it was Jem whom he hired out by the year to the shingle men, for sixty dollars and his keep. The shingle men paid by the thousand. A good getter could rive his task by Thursday and work the rest of the week for himself, and Jem had always been a good getter. Hodges knew that Jem kept the overwork money. He had thought of that as generosity.

The hiring year ran out at Christmas. Every other hired man came walking out of the swamp on Christmas Eve with his pay in his pocket and a sack over his shoulder, to see his people and get drunk or get religion or both. Jem did not come out.

On Sunday evenings that winter Hodges went on reading aloud to his household from the books he had, as he had always done, the Bible and the hymn book and a few others. One of the others was the life of the African, Gustavus Vassa, in the New York printing of 1791, which he had bought in Norfolk because he had heard it called a powerful testimony. He had read it to them twice. The first time through, he noticed afterward, Jem had asked him to read one page over, and then a second time, and then had said it back to him nearly word for word, the page about the man running to the register office with his feet winged with joy. Hodges had been pleased at the time. He had taken it for an interest in the conversion, which came later in the book.

He did not read it that winter. He found he could not, and could not have said why.

II. The Island

The Great Dismal · 1801–1805

There are places in the swamp where the ground lifts a few feet out of the black water and stays dry, and on them the old people built houses of juniper poles and reeds that nobody outside ever saw. Sib had lived on one of them since before the war with the King. Nobody knew whose she had been. Some said she had come in as a girl from the Company's plantation by Suffolk, in the time when they first set people to ditching for the gentlemen who meant to drain the whole Dismal and plant it in rice. Some said she had been born on the island. She was small and very dark and walked with a stick of gallberry, and when Jem came to her in the first week of January 1801, he came with everything he owned on his back.

He had the froe and the maul. He had his blanket and his pot and a sack of meal, and the overwork money sewn into the waist of his breeches, nineteen dollars and some shillings, and a knife, and a pair of shoes he did not wear in the water. He had the whole of a list he had been keeping for nine years: every Christmas, every hire, every dollar the shingle men had paid to Hodges for the use of his arms. He could say it off the way he said off Vassa. He said it to Sib the first night, sitting by her fire, and she listened to the whole of it.

That's heavy, she said.

He said it was his.

I know it is. Set it down a while.

He did not know what she meant, and she did not explain. She did not explain anything, that year or the next. She got up in the dark and went to bed in the dark and between the two she did whatever there was to do, and when there was nothing to do she sat in the door of her house and watched the water. She owned a pot, a gourd, a knife, a blanket and the stick, and when Jem brought her things, a tin cup, a fish, a bolt of osnaburg he had got from the getters, she used them and gave them away. People came to her from the other islands. A woman came with a burned arm and Sib sat with her until the arm was dressed and the woman

stopped shaking. A man came who had heard the dogs behind him for two days, and Sib sat with him until he could hear that they had stopped. The getters said the dogs would not go past the stand of juniper on the near side of her ground, and that a man from Gates County who had followed them past it with a gun had walked in a circle all day and come out where he went in.

Jem rived shingles. That was the trade of the island and of all the islands: the getters who were hired out by the year would take a man's shingles at the edge of the ditches and count them in with their own, and pay him in meal and pork and cloth and whatever money they had over. Every week he carried his thousand out on his head, two bundles lashed together, and every week Sib asked him the same thing when he came back.

What you carrying?

The first year he told her. The list, the dollars, the men in Norfolk who knew his face, the river in 1797 with the ice off the banks, which was the worst of it, because he had come up out of the water free and walked up the bank to the same man. The second year he told her less. In the third year, on a still afternoon in October, when the gums had gone red over the water and he came back from the ditch with the empty lashings in his hand, she asked him, and he stood a long time trying to find it, and could not.

He did not take it for anything. He went down to the water and washed his face. When he came back up she was looking at him the way people look at a boat that has been unloaded, how it sits.

III. The Lock

Deep Creek · March 1806

THE CANAL COMPANY HAD BEEN DIGGING ITS DITCH THROUGH the east side of the swamp since 1793, with hired men and bought men up to their waists in the peat, and in 1805 they let the water through from end to end, twenty-two miles from the Pasquotank to the Elizabeth. It was too shallow yet for anything but flats and log rafts. But the flats

CAME, LOADED TO THE GUNWALES WITH SHINGLES AND STAVES, and at the Deep Creek end, where the water had to be let down to the river, the company built a lock of swamp timber with a keeper's house beside it.

Sib had not come out of the swamp in eleven years. She came out that March because a getter named Moses, who had been taking the island's shingles for most of that time, had been sold away to Carolina over the winter, and the new man would not deal with anybody he had not seen. She sat in the bow of the flat with her stick across her knees. Jem poled. There were eleven thousand shingles in the flat and Moses's brother walking the towpath, to say the load was his.

Ezekiel Hodges was at Deep Creek that morning to see about corn. He had not been looking for anything. He was standing on the walk across the lower gates with the keeper, talking about the price of freight to Norfolk, when the flat came down into the chamber and the keeper went to his paddles, and the water began to go out of the lock under their feet with a long sucking roar, and the flat sank with it slowly between the wet timber walls until the people in it were below him, and he looked down, and it was Jem.

Jem had stepped up from the flat onto the ledge at the gate to fend her off. Hodges reached down and took hold of the shoulder of his shirt. He did it without thinking, the way you grab at something going over a side, and when he had it he closed his hand.

Sib turned around in the bow.

What do you mean by this?

Hodges heard his own voice. *This is my man. This is my man Jem.*

The keeper had stopped with his hand on the paddle gear. The water went on going out. Jem stood on the ledge with his pole in one hand and his shirt in the elder's fist and did not pull away and did not lift his eyes, and Hodges, looking down at him, saw that he was not afraid. He had seen Jem afraid. This was a different face. It was the face of a man resting.

His burden is off him, Sib said.

She said it the way you would tell somebody the river was down. She did not say anything after it.

Hodges had preached the burden for thirty years. He had preached it in barns and in the road and through the bars of a jail, the burden that falls off the back at the foot of the cross and rolls away and is not seen again. He had felt it go from himself at nineteen in a tobacco barn in Sussex County and had told the story at every baptizing since. He had read it out of the African's book to his own household, to this man, by his own fire. He knew what she meant before she had finished saying it. And he knew it was so, because he had seen it in the face before she said it, and had not had a word for it.

Is that so? he said. It came out very quiet.

Yes, said Sib. *It's off him.*

The lock was empty. The keeper looked at the elder and then at the lower gates and then at the elder again, and the elder opened his hand.

He watched the gates swing and the flat go out into Deep Creek on the low water, with the old woman in the bow and Moses's brother walking alongside on the bank, and Jem poling, and he stood on the walk long after the keeper had gone in, with his hand still half closed, as if there were still cloth in it.

IV. These Presents

Near the Great Bridge · March and April 1806

That night he took the African's book down for the first time in five years and sat with it at the kitchen table after the house was asleep. He found the page Jem had said back to him, about the register office and the winged feet, and read it, and could not stay on it. He turned forward to the place he had always liked best, the conversion, where the man at sea in his trouble is shown the cross, and he read the sentence he had read aloud a dozen times in a voice he now could not stand to remember.

> *I felt an astonishing change; the burden of sin, the gaping jaws of hell, and the fears of death, that weighed me down before, now lost their horror.*
>
> *— Olaudah Equiano, The Interesting Narrative, ch. X (1789)*

He sat with that until the candle guttered. A man could have that, the burden of sin lifted, and keep the other burden on another man's back, and call him by his Christian name at a baptizing. He had done it. He would have gone on doing it. What he could not get past was that the one he held had put down both, out there on a hummock among the bears and the reeds, the one the elder had laid on him and the one the elder had preached, and had come up into the lock with nothing on him at all; and that the elder, whose whole life was the falling of burdens, had stood on the walk above him with his fist full of shirt.

He did not know how a deed of manumission was drawn. He had never drawn one. The law since 1782 allowed it, by will or by a writing under hand and seal, proved in the county court. But the Assembly had sat in January and passed a new law, and from the first of May any slave freed after that day who stayed in Virginia more than twelve months could be taken up and sold again. Hodges read it in the Norfolk paper. If the writing was to mean anything for a man who would never leave the swamp, it had to be proved before May.

So he copied the form out of the African's book. It was the only one he had, the paper the merchant of Montserrat had signed in 1766, printed at full length because, the African said, it showed what power one man claims over another. Hodges wrote it out on a clean sheet with the names changed. Where the merchant had written the sum of seventy pounds current money, he wrote *the sum of* and stopped and struck it through.

> To all men unto whom these presents shall come: I Ezekiel Hodges, of the county of Norfolk in the commonwealth of Virginia, send greeting: Know ye, that I the aforesaid Ezekiel Hodges, ~~for and in consideration of the sum of~~ to the intent that a negro man named Jem, aged about thirty-three years, shall and may become free, have

> manumitted, emancipated, enfranchised, and set free, and by these presents do manumit, emancipate, enfranchise, and set free, the aforesaid Jem, for ever, hereby giving, granting, and releasing unto him all right, title, dominion, sovereignty, and property, which as lord and master over the said Jem I had, or now I have, or by any means whatsoever I may or can hereafter possibly have over him, for ever.
> Acknowledged in court, the 21st day of April, 1806.

The clerk read it over twice and looked at the struck words and said the court would take it as it was. Hodges paid the fee and took two attested copies, because the law said a freed man going about without one could be jailed. Then he rode to Deep Creek and waited at the lock for three days, on the walk above the gates, until a flat came down out of the swamp with Moses's brother on the towpath and Jem poling and no old woman in the bow.

She had not come out again. Jem said she was well.

Hodges held out the paper. Jem looked at it a while on the elder's open hand and then took it, and folded it small, and smaller, and put it inside his shirt against his chest, at the shoulder, where the elder had held him. He did not say anything about it. There was nothing in his face that had not been there in March.

He sold his shingles to the new man at Deep Creek and poled the flat back into the chamber, and the keeper shut the gates behind him and opened the paddles, and the water came in roaring from the high side, brown as tea, and the flat came up on it with nothing in her, riding high, past the wet timber, past the elder's boots on the walk, until she was level with the swamp again and the upper gates swung and she went on into it.

Hodges rode home. He had five more names to write, and he knew it, and that was the first night he knew it.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who, even here, knows the end of his suffering, has put down his burden, and is unshackled.*
>
> Dhammapada 402, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin's slave runs away, is ordained (this was before the Buddha made the rule against ordaining slaves) and becomes an arahant. One day the Brahmin sees him entering the city with the Buddha and seizes him by the robe in the gateway. The Buddha turns and asks what he means by it. *This is my slave. His burden has fallen from him.* The Brahmin understands at once that the man is an arahant, asks *Is that so?*, hears *Yes*, and is himself established in the first fruit of the path. Here the gateway is a canal lock, the ordination is four years on a swamp island, and the rule that came afterward is a Virginia law. Read the full commentary story; the verse belongs to the Dhammapada's last chapter, on the true Brahmin.

Deep Creek, Norfolk County, Virginia

The Dismal Swamp, 1801–1806

For more than two centuries the Great Dismal Swamp on the Virginia–North Carolina line sheltered maroons, people who had freed themselves and lived on its dry "islands." After draining for rice failed, the swamp's companies turned to cutting juniper (Atlantic white cedar) for shingles, working enslaved men hired from their owners by the year; the getters could earn money for shingles beyond their task, and maroons supplied them shingles in exchange for goods and cash, a trade Encyclopedia Virginia describes as an informal economy that let the swamp's hidden residents live. The Dismal Swamp Canal, dug largely by enslaved laborers from 1793, opened its full twenty-two miles in 1805, at first to shallow flats and log rafts carrying shingles and staves.

Virginia's manumission act of 1782 let an owner free a slave by will or by a deed proved in the county court, and required the freed person to carry an attested copy. On January 25, 1806, the Assembly passed a new act, in force from May 1, under which anyone freed afterward who stayed in the state more than twelve months could be seized and sold. Olaudah Equiano's *Interesting Narrative* (London 1789; New York, W. Durell, 1791) prints in full the deed by which the Montserrat merchant Robert King freed him in 1766; the form the elder copies, and the two passages he reads, are Equiano's words.

After the story of a certain Brahmin from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 402). The original. Quotations from Olaudah Equiano, *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (1789). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.20

The Feather Trees

There is a Power whose care
Teaches thy way along that pathless coast,—
The desert and illimitable air,—
Lone wandering, but not lost.
— William Cullen Bryant, "To a Waterfowl"

This is how I heard it, in Magnolia Park.

I. The Book

Observation Post Item-41, Burbank, California · May 1944

The post was a plywood shack on the roof of Inez Albright's two-car garage, with a telephone, a stool, a pair of Navy binoculars, a chart of silhouettes tacked to the wall and a ledger that the Army called the post log and everyone on the block called the Book. You went up by a ladder from the alley. The Army had put it there in the winter of 1942, when nobody knew yet whether the Japanese would come over the San Gabriels some night, and it had been manned every hour since, in four-hour watches, by forty-one volunteers from the streets around, most of them women, most of them over fifty, two of them Boy Scouts.

Mrs. Albright was chief observer because she had more hours than anybody and because she could tell a Vega from a Harvard by the sound before it cleared the roofs. She was sixty-four. In 1919 she had flown a Jenny upside down over the Pomona fair with her husband standing on the top wing, and later, after he was killed doing it at Bakersfield, she had taught flying for sixteen years at a dirt field out in the Valley until the war shut down private flying along the coast. Since then she had flown nothing. She wore her husband's leather coat on the night watches and

kept her Fourth Reader from Kansas on the shelf under the telephone, with a poem in it she had made all her students learn.

Across the street and three blocks east, where the Lockheed plant had been, there was a suburb.

It was not there. It was a canopy of chicken wire and netting and painted canvas laid over the factory and the parking lots on poles, with streets painted on it, and burlap houses with burlap roofs, and trees made of feathers glued onto wire and sprayed green and brown. The airfield next door was painted to look like alfalfa. Men from the studios had designed it, painters and set builders who had been making Kansas and Paris and the moon out of lath for twenty years. The swing shift went to work underneath it through tunnels. On their breaks men went up through hatches and moved the canvas cars around, and took in laundry from the clotheslines at the burlap bungalows, so that from five thousand feet it would look as if someone lived there. Everybody on Mrs. Albright's street had feathers in their gutters. The kids played with them.

On the sixteenth of May the Secretary of War said in the papers that the Aircraft Warning Service would be inactivated. The order came down to the post a few days after: secure the telephone and turn in the Book on the twenty-ninth. Mrs. Albright read it out at the change of watch and then put it in the back of the Book with the rest, and went on.

> 1530 Mrs. Ochs on post. Clear, wind W light. Feathers on roof again, swept.
>
> 1612 Army Flash. Item-41. Two, single-motor, low, seen, one mile east, heading north. (Ours. Harvards.)
>
> 1930 Mrs. Albright on post. Mr. Purcell asks is it true we're closing. It is true.
>
> 2105 Visitor on post, by permission of chief obs. Mr. S. Stayed to 2350. No traffic.

II. The Visitor

The garage roof · nights

THE VISITOR WAS MR. SAXE. EVERYBODY ON THE STREET KNEW the car, which was a Packard as long as a hearse with a driver who sat in it all night reading, and everybody knew who he was, because he ran a studio, one of the big ones over the hill. Mrs. Ochs said he had a thousand cameras. She meant it the way people meant it then, that he could see anything he wanted to see, anywhere in the world, and make you see it too.

He had first come up the ladder in March, in a white suit, asking whether it was true that Inez Albright of the old Albright Flying Circus was on this roof. His studio had hired her in 1927 to fly through a barn for a picture about the war in France, and she had flown through the barn, and he had never forgotten it. After that he came every week or two, after dark, and sat on an apple box with his back against the shack while she watched the sky, and she talked to him in the plain pleasant way she talked to everybody, about the Jenny and the fairs and the wind off the Tehachapis, and about nothing, and he listened like a man drinking water.

He told her one night that his own art department had designed half the canopy across the street.

It's good work, she said. *Nobody can find it.*

Nobody?

One girl could. One of mine. She said you look for the railroad. There's a spur that runs under the netting, and from up high it starts in the middle of a street and stops in the middle of a field. Everything else in that suburb goes somewhere. You look for the track that doesn't.

Mr. Saxe laughed and wrote it down in a little book, and then sat looking at what he had written for a long time.

> 2140 Mr. S. on post again. Asked could he take a watch. Told him not without the course. He said what course. Chief obs. explained.
>
> 2215 Army Flash. Item-41. One, multi-motor, high, heard, distance unknown, heading west.

> 2300 Mr. S. asked chief obs. what she does up here all night when nothing comes. Chief obs. says she looks. (D.K.)

III. One, Bi-motor

The garage roof · Thursday, May 25, 1944

Danny Kowalski, fifteen, of the Scout troop at St. Finbar's, had the early evening watch with Mrs. Albright that Thursday, because his mother worked swing at the plant and because he liked the binoculars. He was the one who wrote it in the Book. He kept the Book that summer, after it was over, in a drawer of his bureau, until the Army sent a man in a car to ask for it back, and he gave the man the Book but copied the page first, and kept the copy.

There had been a postcard at noon, from Long Beach. Mrs. Albright had read it on the porch and said nothing about it, which was usual, but she had gone up the ladder half an hour before her watch, which was not. At six-thirty the Packard came up the street and stopped at the curb, and Mr. Saxe came up the ladder in his white suit with a paper sack of cherries from the market on Magnolia, and sat on his box with his back to the shack and offered the cherries round. The sky over Glendale was going rose and then red. Swallows were working the air over the canopy, coming down very low over the painted streets and the feather trees and the burlap roofs, and Danny would always remember that, that the birds were not fooled, that they went for the bugs over the vacant lots and the wash and let the feather trees alone.

At 7:41 by the post clock he heard her before he saw her, the sound of two Allisons, which is a sound like no other, coming low out of the north. He had the glasses up and the receiver in his other hand before Mrs. Albright said a word.

She came in over the roofs at perhaps four hundred feet, a P-38 still in her factory skin, twin booms and the long middle nacelle like a pair of tongs carrying a cigar, so low that the feathers stood up off the canopy behind her and went whirling. Danny could see the dark of the helmet

behind the glass, and the head turned toward them, looking down at the roof. Looking down at the street. At the Packard at the curb.

She did not come round again. She rocked her wings once, left and right, slowly, over the garage, the way a person bows from across a room, and banked off south toward Long Beach and the last of the light, and was a sound, and then was nothing.

> 1941 Army Flash. Item-41. One, bi-motor, very low, seen, overhead, heading S. P-38. Ours. Rocked wings over post. Did not circle. (D.K.)

Mr. Saxe had stood up. He had a cherry in his fingers and had forgotten it.

Who was that?

That was my girl, Mrs. Albright said. She was still looking south. *That was Kay. She was coming by. I expect she saw she'd be interrupting.*

Kay, he said. Then he said a name, a different last name, the one that had been on the posters, and she nodded. He had had the girl under contract from 1936 to 1939. She had the most famous face on his lot, a face that men wrote letters to by the sackful, and she had loved it, and he had built three pictures on it, and in the spring of 1939 she had walked off the lot in the middle of the fourth and he had never known why. There had been talk. There had been a lawsuit, which he had won.

She came out to my field that summer, Mrs. Albright said. *Wanted to learn. I told her people only want to learn to fly to be looked at, and she said that's exactly why she wanted to learn, to be somewhere nobody could. I never had a better one. She can find a field in the dark by the smell of it. She can find your factory.*

The railroad.

She knows what's a street and what's chicken wire, said Mrs. Albright. *That's all flying is. She's in the WASPs now, out of Long Beach. Ferrying. She takes them off the line over there and puts them down wherever the Army says, and comes back on the train, and does it again.* She sat down on the stool. *She's got where she was going, Mr. Saxe. There's nothing she wants. I don't think I ever met anybody else I could say that about.*

Mr. Saxe did not say anything. Mrs. Albright reached under the telephone and took down the Fourth Reader, which fell open by itself, and handed it to Danny without a word, because it was the custom of the post that whoever logged a ship read the poem, and Danny read it out loud to the studio man in the last red light, embarrassed, all of it, the way they had learned it in the eighth grade.

Vainly the fowler's eye
Might mark thy distant flight to do thee wrong,
As, darkly painted on the crimson sky,
Thy figure floats along.

...

There is a Power whose care
Teaches thy way along that pathless coast,—
The desert and illimitable air,—
Lone wandering, but not lost.

— William Cullen Bryant, "To a Waterfowl"

The feathers she had stirred were still coming down, over the canopy and the street and the roof of the garage, green and brown, very slowly, because they were so light. One landed on the white sleeve of the studio man's suit. He looked at it a while. Then he set it on the shelf by the telephone, beside the Reader, and went down the ladder, and the Packard went away down the street with its lights hooded.

> 2010 Mr. S. off post. Left cherries.

IV. Secure the Telephone

Monday, May 29, 1944

He did not come back. On the last night half the block climbed the ladder by turns to sit a while, and there were more people on the roof than the roof was built for, and nothing came over at all. At midnight Mrs. Albright made the last entry in her square hand and closed

THE BOOK AND TIED IT WITH THE STRING, AND DANNY COPIED the page into his school notebook before the man from the Army came for it in August.

> 2400 Post Item-41 secured per orders. Manned 20,352 hours since Feb. 1, 1942. No enemy aircraft observed. All ours. — I.A.

The canopy came down after the war, and the factory stood out in the sun again with its sawtooth roofs, and the men who took the netting off found swallows nesting in the feather trees. Mrs. Albright flew again in 1946, a rented Cub out of a field in Van Nuys, and in her eighties she was still telling people that you look for the track that doesn't go anywhere. She kept the feather on the shelf over her kitchen sink until it was gray. Kay never flew over again that anybody saw. She did not need to. The old woman said she knew where she was.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana whose knowledge is deep, who possesses wisdom, who knows the right way and the wrong, and has attained the highest end.*
>
> Dhammapada 403, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Sakka, lord of the gods, comes one night with his retinue to hear the Buddha speak. The nun Khemā sets out through the air to visit the Teacher, sees Sakka there, pays her respects without coming down, turns around and goes. Sakka asks who she was, and the Buddha answers: *my daughter Khemā, of great wisdom, who knows well what is the path and what is not the path,* and speaks the verse. Khemā had been the queen of King Bimbisāra, so proud of her beauty that she avoided the Buddha, and became the foremost of his nuns in wisdom. Here Sakka is a studio head, the "thousand eyes" are cameras, and the path that is not a path is a painted street. Read the full commentary story and about Khemā.

Burbank, California

Burbank, 1944

After Pearl Harbor the Army hid the Lockheed plant in Burbank, where the P-38 Lightning was built, under a canopy of chicken wire, netting and painted canvas meant to look from the air like an ordinary California suburb, with artists and set designers from Disney, Paramount and 20th Century Fox helping. Trees were made of chicken feathers glued to wire and sprayed green and brown, the airfield and lots were painted to pass for alfalfa, and workers took in laundry at the "burlap bungalows" on their breaks. A longtime Lockheed man recalled, as LAist reports, that the only giveaway from the air was a railroad track that seemed to begin and end inside the canopy.

The Aircraft Warning Service put hundreds of thousands of civilian volunteers on observation posts who phoned "flash" reports of every plane they saw or heard to Army filter centers; in May 1944 the War Department announced its inactivation, effective May 29. Some 130 Women Airforce Service Pilots flew pursuit planes for the Air Transport Command, among them pilots of the 6th Ferrying Group at Long Beach, ferrying aircraft from the factories, as the WASP Museum recounts.

After the story of the nun Khemā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 403). The original. Poetry from William Cullen Bryant, "To a Waterfowl," as printed in his *Poems* (1854). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.21

Foot Water

> *(Of whom the world was not worthy:) they wandered in deserts, and in mountains, and in dens and caves of the earth.*
> *— Hebrews 11:38*

This is how I heard it, on the Green River.

I. The Praying Man

The bluffs above the Green River, Hart County, Kentucky · June 1884

I WILL TELL IT THE WAY IT HAPPENED TO ME, BECAUSE NOBODY else saw my side of it, and I am the one who did the wrong.

I lived in the cave above Joppa with my three. You know the one if you are from there. It opens under a ledge in the bluff where the sinkhole woods come down to the river, low at the mouth so a grown person has to stoop, and then it stands up tall inside and goes back a long way, and there is water in it that you hear before you find. Cold all year. The same cold in August as in January, so that in summer the air comes out of the mouth like breath, and the boys from Joppa used to dare each other to stand in it. They did not come in. They said a woman lived in there. That was so.

I came in the winter of the big snow, before the war, with Phebe who was eight and Lewis who was five and the baby I had not named yet, because you wait. We had come up out of Barren County four nights walking, and they were behind us with the dogs, and the river was too high and too cold, and the cave was there. I meant to stay one night. I am not going to tell you more about that winter than that we did not come out. You can understand it or not. After a while the cold did not trouble us,

and the dark was a house, and the four of us kept it. Thirty years. It is a long time, if you are counting, and I was not.

He came up the bluff path in the middle of June, in the morning. A man past forty, dark and spare, in a hickory shirt washed nearly white, barefooted, with his shoes tied together by the laces and hung round his neck and a blanket roll on his back and nothing else. He stooped under the ledge and stood up inside, out of the sun, and he did not look around the way people look in a cave, for snakes or for treasure. He sat down on the flat rock just inside the drip line, where the water comes off the ledge in a fringe when it has rained, and put his hands on his knees, and was still.

I have had people in my cave. Boys on a dare. A drunk white man in '71 who slept a night and went out screaming. Two surveyors with a candle and a line. None of them were still. This one was still the way the river is still at the bottom of a deep hole, where it is moving all the time and you can't see it, and the stillness came off him into the cave like the cold comes out of it, and I could not abide it. I have no other way to say it. It was like being looked at with a light by somebody who is not looking at you at all. The children felt it. Lewis went back into the dark behind the water and would not come out.

I said to myself, he is a traveling preacher looking for a cool place to sleep. He will stay the night. I took the three by the hand and went out of my own house, up through the sinkhole woods, and sat under the beeches the whole night through like a woman put out in the road, and waited for him to leave.

II. Looking Back Along Him

Joppa and the bluff · June and July

In the morning he went down to Joppa. I followed him. Nobody sees me if I don't want them to.

Joppa was eleven houses then, and a church of hewed logs that doubled for the school, and a store that belonged to a white man in Munfordville. He walked through it the way a man walks through a place

where he means to ask for something, slow, and he stopped at nobody's door, and at the last house before the woods Viney Hollins came out on her step with flour on her hands and looked at him and called him in.

She knew who he was. Everybody in that country knew Brother Isom Gaines, though most had never laid eyes on him. He was the one Mother Easter Tolliver had raised up out of her church at Little Zion, who preached when they asked him and did not ask, and had no house, and ate what was put in front of him. Viney sat him at her table and gave him cornbread and buttermilk and a plate of greens. Then she brought her washpan, the tin one with the dent, because his feet were cut from the bluff, and knelt and washed them, and dried them on her apron. She asked him where he was staying. He said in the cave above. She asked him how long. He said Mother Easter had given him a word to carry, and he meant to sit with it through laying-by, if the Lord was willing.

Then you come here every day for your dinner, Viney said. *Every day. You hear me? Till the crop's laid by and after.*

He said he would. And I knew then he wasn't going to leave.

I knew the word Mother Easter had given him, too, because he said it over walking. I heard it all the way up the bluff path that day and every day after. She had told him to go off by himself and count what he was made of. Every part. So he counted it, coming and going, the way you'd say a lesson. *The hair of the head. The hair of the body. The nails. The teeth. The skin.* And on, inward: the flesh and the sinews and the bones and the marrow, the heart and the liver, the lights, the bowels, down to the spit and the sweat and the tears and the water. Over and over, all the way down to the river and all the way back up, as if he were taking an inventory of a house he had been lent.

Half a month went by, and I sat in the beech woods with my three. He did not go. He sat on the flat rock inside my door from before light until dinner and from dinner until dark and went in and lay down on his blanket by my water and slept like a child. I could not go in. I could not have gone in any more than you could lie down on a stove.

I thought: everybody has something. If I could find it, I could tell him. I could stand in my own door and say it to his face, and he would pick up his blanket and go.

The dead see the way water runs, all the way back to where it came from. I looked back along him. I looked along his whole life the way you look up a creek from the mouth, every turn of it, every snag. I saw him born on a place in Barren County not twelve miles from where I was born. I saw them sell his mother off it when he was six, and I saw him at sixteen knock down a white boy who struck him and take the whipping for it. I saw him freed at twenty-one, in the December the law came down, walking off that place with a hoe on his shoulder that he carried back the next morning because it wasn't his. I saw him go down in the Green River to be baptized in 1866 with Mother Easter on the bank, and come up.

And from the day he came up out of that water I looked for one thing, for a speck, for a flyspeck, the way you'd look over a sheet you meant to sell. He married and buried his wife and gave her brother the land. He worked other men's tobacco for wages and took the wages and nothing over. He preached at forty brush arbors and would not let them take up a collection. When men cussed him he waited. When women looked at him he looked at the ground. He never took one thing that wasn't handed to him. I went over it twice. I went over it three times.

There was nothing. He was clean as a peeled stick. I sat under the beeches and hated him for it, and then I thought of something.

III. The Boy

Viney Hollins's house · a Tuesday in July

I AM GOING TO TELL THIS PART PLAINLY AND NOT MAKE IT ANY better than it was.

Viney had four. The least one was Sam, five years old, with a head like a little brown egg and a way of following the preacher down to the gate every day and walking along beside him a piece, saying the parts over

with him to show he knew them. *The teeth. The skin.* On a Tuesday in July, in the morning, while his mother was at the churn, I went into that child.

I had been a mother. I want you to know I knew what I was doing. I took him by the throat from inside and closed it. He fell down on the floor of the kitchen and his heels went on the boards, and his eyes stood out of his head, and the froth came out of his mouth, and Viney left the churn and fell on her knees and took him up and screamed, *What is this, what is this, Jesus, what is this,* and I spoke to her out of the air of her own kitchen.

I have got your boy, I said. *I don't want nothing for him. But that praying man that eats at your table carries a root. You go ask him for a piece of it, and boil it down in lard, and put it in the child's nose, and I will turn him loose.*

That was the whole of my plan. If he gave it, he was a root doctor. Everybody on the river would know it by Sunday, and a preacher who gives out roots is no preacher, and he would have to go.

Viney held her boy against her with his heels drumming and his face going dark, and she looked up at nothing, at me, and her face was wet all over, and she said:

Then let him go to Jesus. I will not ask that man for any root. I will not make Brother Isom a root doctor in front of God and Joppa. Let him go.

I had not expected that. I tried again.

Then have him tie a bag of asafetida round the child's neck with his own hands.

No. I won't ask him that either.

I could feel the boy going. I could feel how little there was left in him, how soon. I had not wanted that. I don't know what I had wanted.

Then wash his feet when he comes, I said, *the way you do. And take the water you washed them in and put it on this child's head.*

Viney stopped crying. She sat on her heels on her kitchen floor and looked a long time at nothing.

That I can do, she said.

And I let the throat open a little, so the child could breathe, and lie in his mother's lap, and wait.

IV. Foot Water

The same day, at dinner

He came down the path at noon the way he always came, saying the parts, and Sam was not at the gate. Viney met him at the step with her face scrubbed and her eyes red and sat him down at the table and put the bread in front of him and the buttermilk, and while he ate she brought the dented washpan, and knelt, and washed his feet, the way she did every day, and dried them on her apron.

Then she stood up with the pan in her two hands.

Brother Isom, she said. *Sam is sick. I want to put this water on my boy's head.*

He looked at the pan. He looked at the child in the corner on the pallet with his throat working. If he had a thought about it, it did not get as far as his face.

Put it, then, he said.

She poured it on the boy's head, all of it, and it ran down into his ears and his collar and the tick of the pallet, gray with the dust of my bluff, and I let him go. He sat up coughing and hollered for his mother, and she grabbed him to her wet and all and rocked him there on the floor, and the preacher finished his bread, and thanked her for it, and put his shoes back round his neck, and went out the gate.

I was at my door before him.

V. Root Doctor

The mouth of the cave · afternoon

It had rained in the night and the fringe was coming off the ledge, a line of drops all across the mouth, and the flat rock inside it was dark with wet. He came up the last of the path saying *the bones, the marrow, the kidneys,* and stooped under the ledge, and I stood up in my own door and said it with all I had.

Doctor! Root doctor! Don't you come in here!

He stopped where he was, on the flat rock, with the drops coming down all round him.

Who is that?

It's me that lives here.

And I watched him do what I had done. I watched him turn and look back along his own life, the whole length of it, from the river in 1866 to the rock he was standing on, looking for the day he doctored anybody. He took his time. He looked the way an honest man counts money that isn't his.

I never doctored nobody, he said.

You never?

Never.

Then I will tell you.

Tell me.

Stand back from my door first. Now. Didn't Viney Hollins this very day take the water she washed your feet in and pour it on her boy's head, when he was took?

She did.

Well.

Is that what you mean?

That is what I mean.

Then something happened in him that I had never seen happen in anybody, living or dead.

I had gone over his life three times with all the sight the dead have, and so had he, just now, and the worst either of us could find in eighteen years was the dirty water off his feet. He understood that. I watched him understand it. And a gladness came up in him like the river comes up in March, all at once and from underneath, so strong that I stepped back from it into my own dark. I thought he would shout. A preacher would have shouted. He did not. He held it down the way you put your hand over a lamp chimney in a draft, not to put it out, to keep it steady, and he stood there on the wet rock and did not lift a foot, while the drops came off the ledge and ran down the back of his neck, and whatever he had come there to finish, he finished it, standing there. I saw it go through. I

don't have a word for it any more than I had a word for the stillness. He was a man with nothing left on him to count.

Then he looked straight at me, and I knew he could see me, and I knew he had always been able to.

You told a lie on a clean man, he said. *You can't stay here now. Go on.*

Then he said, and it was not hard, it was the voice you'd use to a mule that's stood too long in a stall, *And there's no call for you to stay here, Sister. Nobody's hunting you. They quit in '65. Get your children and go on.*

Nobody tells the dead anything. Nobody had told me. Thirty winters I had kept that cave against the dogs, and the dogs were dead, and the men were old or dead, and the place in Barren County had been sold twice, and nobody had come up the bluff to say it.

I went and got them out of the back. Phebe had the baby. Lewis would not let go of my skirt. We came up to the mouth, and he stepped off the rock to let us by, and we went out past him into the light, which did not hurt.

VI. Little Zion

The district association, under the beeches · August 1884

I HAVE BEEN OTHER PLACES SINCE. BUT I WENT TO THE ASSOCIation first, in August, because I wanted to see what they would make of him.

It met that year at Little Zion, in the grove, with tables of dinner under the trees and the preachers of eleven churches on the benches and the people standing all round, and Brother Isom came walking in on the third day out of the woods with his shoes round his neck. They asked him had he finished what he went to do. He said he had. Then they made him tell it, the cave and Viney and the foot water and the woman at the door, and he told it the way he told everything, without any shine on it.

And she called you a root doctor, said one of the preachers, *right to your face. And you were not angry.*

No.

Not at all?

No.

The preachers looked at each other. They went to the front bench where Mother Easter Tolliver was sitting with her stick between her knees, ninety years old, so small her feet did not reach the ground, and the oldest of them bent down and said it to her low.

Mother, that boy is telling a story. Any man would have got mad.

Mother Easter did not look up at him. She was looking at Isom, across the grove, where he stood by himself at the edge of the trees.

That one don't get mad, she said. *He don't run with the members and he don't run with the preachers. He hasn't got a house to keep. He don't want nothing.*

Then she put her hand out, and somebody put a Bible in it, and she could not read, she had never read, but she opened it to the place she wanted by the feel of the pages, the way you find a step in the dark, and gave it to the preacher to read out, and he read it out.

> *They were stoned, they were sawn asunder, were tempted, were slain with the sword: they wandered about in sheepskins and goatskins; being destitute, afflicted, tormented; (Of whom the world was not worthy:) they wandered in deserts, and in mountains, and in dens and caves of the earth.*
>
> *— Hebrews 11:37–38*

I was standing at the back among the people, with my three. Nobody saw us. Destitute, afflicted, tormented. In a den and a cave of the earth. I had not known there was any word for us in that book. I had not known anybody had written it down.

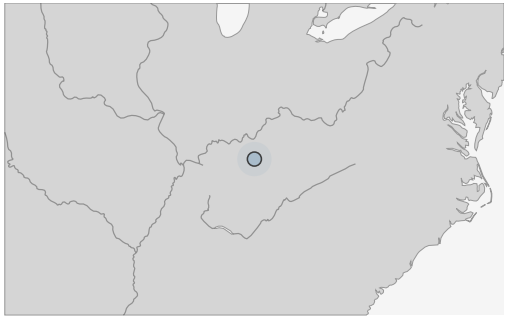
I went back once more to the cave, at the end, to look. Nobody lives there now. The boys from Joppa go in all the way to the water and come out laughing. The flat rock is still inside the drip line, and when it has rained in the night the fringe comes off the ledge and wets the whole of it, all but two places the shape of a man's bare feet, side by side, where he stood that afternoon and did not move; and those stay dry.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who keeps aloof both from laymen and from mendicants, who frequents no houses, and has but few desires.*
>
> Dhammapada 404, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the monk Tissa takes a meditation subject from the Buddha and settles for the rains in a rock cave, fed by a laywoman of the village. The deity who lives in the cave cannot bear to share it with so virtuous a man; she searches his whole life for a flaw and finds none, then seizes the laywoman's youngest son and demands, in turn, that the woman get licorice, then resin powder, from the monk as medicine. The woman refuses to make him a physician, but agrees to sprinkle the water she bathed his feet in on the boy's head. Then the deity stands at the cave mouth and calls Tissa *great physician*. He reviews his life, finds no speck on his conduct, feels great joy, restrains it, and becomes an arahant without lifting a foot; he tells the deity to leave. When the monks refuse to believe he was not angry, the Buddha speaks the verse. The thirty-two parts of the body he recites are the meditation subject. Read the full commentary story and about the contemplation of the body's parts.



Green River bluffs, Hart County, Kentucky

The Green River country, 1884

Kentucky stayed in the Union and was exempt from the Emancipation Proclamation, so slavery there ended only when the Thirteenth Amendment took effect in December 1865. The limestone country along the Green River is riddled with caves and sinkholes; at nearby Mammoth Cave enslaved men mined saltpeter and, from 1838, enslaved guides such as Stephen Bishop and Mat and Nick Bransford explored and led tours, and Bransford descendants went on guiding into the 1930s.

Freed Black Kentuckians built their own churches quickly after the war. In 1869 delegates met at the First Baptist Church of Lexington to organize the Kentucky General Association of Colored Baptists; its constitution provided for messengers from the district associations into which local churches gathered. Joppa, Little Zion and their people are fictional.

After the story of the elder Pabbhāravāsī Tissa from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 404). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.22

The Hickory Stick

we must not inflict pain, harm or sorrow upon any one
— Dordrecht Confession (1632), art. XIV

Wie ich's gheert hab, at the wall of the Salford burying ground.

I. The Wall

Lower Salford, Montgomery County · March 1828

They have put you in the row by your father, Velte, and the clay is so wet it shines. I am standing outside the wall because I have stood outside it for fifty-two years and my legs do not know another place to stand. Your brother Abraham's widow is inside, by the hole, with her hands in her apron. She saw me come up the lane. She knows what I have under my shawl. She is the only one living who does.

Nobody in there will say anything over you that is about you. That is your people's way, and it was my mother's, and it was mine until I was nineteen and married Philip Schlosser at the Reformed church on the Skippack Road. A preacher read. They sang a long hymn out of the thick book, lined out, one line and then all of them after it. Then the men took up the shovels. The boards they let you down on were planed. That is the whole of it. You were seventy-three.

I have things to say to you that I did not say on the road, because on the road you never once turned around.

II. The Road

The Great Road below the Swamp · April 1778

THAT SPRING THE ENGLISH HAD THE CITY AND OUR ARMY WAS starving at the Valley Forge, twenty miles off, and the militia under General Lacey was riding the roads between the two rivers to stop farmers from carrying anything into Philadelphia, where the English paid in hard money. Philip was a sergeant in it. He was a smith by trade, and he shod the militia horses for nothing, and on his nights home he talked about the Mennists.

Non-jurors, he called them, because they would not take the Test oath, and Tories, which they were not, and other things. Your people paid the fines for not mustering. Your people would not take Continental paper if they could help it. Most of them would not pay the war tax either, and up at Franconia there was trouble over Preacher Funk, who said they should. Philip had all this by heart. He said it at the table with his mouth full.

On the fourteenth of April he came home and told me, as a good joke, that he and four men had stopped a wagon on the Salford road that morning going down to the city with butter and eggs, and the wagon belonged to an old Mennist widow, and they had made her stand and watch while they broke every egg in the road and tipped the butter in the ditch, and the dogs had come.

It was my mother's wagon. He knew it. That was the joke.

I don't remember what I said. I remember he went out to the forge, and I put on my cloak and walked out the other door, and I set my face toward Salford, eleven miles, because I meant to go home to her and not come back.

It was not a road for a woman alone that spring. There were deserters from both armies in the woods, and foragers, and men who said they were one and were the other. A mile below our place I saw a man walking ahead of me with an axe on his shoulder and a bundle hung from the helve. A broad hat. A plain coat with nothing on it worth stealing. I knew what he was by his back, the way you know your own people by their

backs even after you have left them: he walked without looking to the side at anything, as if the road were a row he was hoeing.

So I kept behind him. Thirty steps, then twenty. I thought, if anything comes out of the woods, it will see a man with an axe first.

He never looked around. I want you to know that I watched for it. Six miles, and you never turned your head, not when my shoe scraped, not when I coughed to see if you would. I have thought since that you knew I was there the whole way, the way you know the weather is behind you, and that it was nothing to you either way, and I was sore about that for a while, if you want the truth. A woman likes to be looked at, even by a Mennist.

III. The Axe

The same road, toward evening

PHILIP CAME UP BEHIND US AT THE FORD BELOW THE MILL, riding one of the militia horses. He had his hickory stick, the one he carried for dogs, as thick as a woman's wrist at the knob end and worn dark where his hand went.

He did not say anything to me. He rode past me and pulled the horse across the road in front of you and got down.

Where are you taking her.

You looked at him. You did not look at me even then.

I said, *Philip, he never looked at me. He never said one word. I walked behind him on my own. Leave him be.*

So you took yourself off, he said, *behind a Mennist.* And then, and I have heard it every day since: *Then he can have what you have coming.*

Velte, I have told this to nobody but Barbara and my own daughter, and now you.

You took the axe off your shoulder. Philip stepped back, and I thought, God help us, now. And you bent and laid it down in the road. You did not drop it. You laid it down the way my mother laid a loaf on the board, with the bit turned toward the ditch and the helve along the wheel rut, where

no hand could come at it quickly, not his, not yours. You put the bundle beside it. Then you stood up and let your hands hang.

He beat you across the back and shoulders. Then the arms. You went down on one knee once in the mud of the ford and got up again, and you did not put up your hands, and you did not make a sound I could hear over his breathing. I screamed at him. He hit you until he was tired, which was a long time, because he was a smith.

Then he put me up on the horse in front of him like a sack and turned for home. I looked back. You were standing in the road bareheaded, looking at nothing, the way a man looks at the sky to see if it will rain. Then you bent and picked up your hat and your bundle and your axe, and went on south.

Philip and I did not talk about it. Not that night, not in thirty-three years. I stayed. I am not telling you this to be pitied. I had one child by then and another coming. I stayed, and I learned the price of butter, and I learned which way to stand at the table.

IV. What Barbara Told Me

Abraham Hunsberger's kitchen, Lower Salford · that night

Barbara told me the rest in 1811, at my mother's burying, when I had come back for the first time and stood at this same wall. She came out to me through the gate. She said, *You are the one from the ford,* and I said I was, and she told it to me the way you would hand a woman back something she had dropped.

You came in after dark. Abraham was at the table, and your brothers Jacob and Christian, and Barbara at the fire. You had been the whole winter in the Swamp, cutting cordwood for your aunt Anna, a widow on a timber lot past the Milford line with nobody to cut for her, and they had not seen you since the first snow. You set the axe in its corner. You said you would eat later. You said you had to go over to the old preacher's in the morning and tell him something.

Barbara saw the blood come through your shirt when you sat.

She got the shirt off you, and it was stuck. She said the weals stood up on your back like the ribs in corduroy, so many that she started counting to keep her hands steady, and stopped at thirty because there was no more back to count on. She warmed goose grease in a saucer and put it on with two fingers while the boys held the candle.

Who did this.

You told them. The ford, the woman behind, the smith with the stick. You told it plainly, as if you were telling where you had seen a fox.

Jacob said, *And what did you say to him?*

There was nothing to say.

But were you angry? Velte. When he was doing it. Were you angry at him?

No.

Barbara said the kitchen went still. You have to understand, she said to me, it was worse than the beating. In that house a man's yea was yea and his nay was nay, without any oath to hold it up. That was the whole of why your people would not swear to the Test, why they were fined and called Tories and had their eggs broken in the road. Their word was the oath. And here was Velte, home from the woods, saying No to something any child in Salford knew could not be no. Abraham said it first. *He is lying.* Christian said it. And Jacob, who loved you best, said, *Velte, it is a sin to say that if it is not true. Say you were angry and be done.*

You said, *I was not angry,* and went up to bed.

In the morning the three of them went across the fields ahead of you, to old Hannes Detweiler.

V. The Loom

The weaver's house on the Indian Creek road · the next morning

Barbara went with them, because she had the saucer of goose grease in her apron and meant to take it on to you after. So she heard it.

Detweiler was past seventy. He had been a weaver all his life and a preacher since 1742, when the lot fell on him: the slip of paper in the hymnbook, the one with the verse on it, *The lot is cast into the lap.* He used

to say the lot had made a mistake and been too proud to take it back. He was at his loom when they came in, throwing the shuttle, and he did not stop.

Abraham told it. The smith, the ford, thirty weals and more. And then: *He says he was not angry. We think he is lying. We have come to you because it is a lie in the face of the whole congregation, and we do not know what to do with a brother who lies about a thing like that.*

The old man threw the shuttle and beat the weft up with the batten and threw it back.

Was it you, he said, *who sent him to the Swamp? Or was it me?*

It was you.

It was me. In November. He came here with his fists like this. He showed them, without letting go of the shuttle. *He had been in the road when the militia took the Bergeys' horses, and he wanted to hit somebody, and he was frightened of how much. So I gave him your aunt's cordwood and one thing to do with it. I said, Velte, when you lift the axe, know that you are lifting it. When you lay it down, lay it down. Every stroke. Not one stroke without knowing it. He said, That is all? I said, That is enough for a winter.*

He threw the shuttle.

He laid it down in the Swamp, he said. *Somewhere in March, I would think. Ask him the day. He has come home to tell me, and I can see from here he does not need to. What he picked up off the road yesterday was an axe. It was only an axe.*

Then he stopped the loom, Barbara said, which he did not do for anybody, and got down the little book of the Confession from the shelf where it lay with his Testament, the confession the ministers of this country had owned for theirs in 1725, and found the place without looking long, and read it out to the four of them in the German, standing, as if they were all in meeting.

> *From this we understand that therefore, and according to His example, we must not inflict pain, harm or sorrow upon any one, but seek the highest welfare and salvation of all men … that we must not harm any one, and, when we are smitten, rather turn the other cheek also, than take revenge or retaliate.*
>
> *— Dordrecht Confession (1632), art. XIV, "Of Revenge"*

We all say that, he told them. *Sundays. We have it by heart and we pay the fines for it. Your brother has got to where it is true of him, that is the only difference, and it is a hard thing to see in somebody you grew up with, so you call it a lie. He did not lie. Go home. Abraham, put him on light work until his back closes. Barbara, you have something in your apron for him.*

They went home across the wheat. You were in the yard splitting kindling with your shirt off because of the grease, and the weals were turning the color of plums, and Barbara said you lifted the hatchet, and brought it down, and set it on the block, and lifted it, so slowly that the boys, who had come to say something to you, stood at the fence and could not think what it had been.

VI. The Stick

The Salford burying ground · March 1828

Philip died in the fall of 1811 at the forge, of his heart, with the tongs in his hand. I buried him in the Reformed ground on the Skippack Road under a stone with his name on it and a willow, because that is what we do.

The stick hung behind the forge door for thirty-three years. He never carried it again after that April. I do not say that means anything. He did not say. Some days I thought he was ashamed of it, and some days I thought he was keeping it the way a man keeps a gun he has used. When he died I took it into the house. My daughter wanted it for the fire. I said no. I have had it in the corner by my bed for seventeen years, and every winter I have asked myself why, and the answer I have come to is that I

was waiting to give it back to somebody, and there was only ever one person it could go to.

The men are filling you in now. Barbara is looking at me. She is near eighty and she still holds her apron the same way, as if there were a saucer in it.

I am going to go in at the gate, Velte, the first time since I was nineteen. Nobody will stop me. Your people do not stop anybody; that was always the trouble with them, Philip said. I am going to walk up the row to the new clay and lay this down on it, the knob end toward your father's stone and the rest along the length of you, the way you laid your axe along the wheel rut at the ford. Then I am going to walk back out and down the lane and home, and there will be nobody in front of me, and I will not need anybody to be.

There are no flowers in this ground and no willows, and the stones are all one height. It will be the only thing lying on any grave here, a dark old stick worn smooth at one end by a hand, and I do not think anybody will pick it up.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who finds no fault with other beings, whether feeble or strong, and does not kill nor cause slaughter.*
>
> Dhammapada 405, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a monk takes a meditation subject from the Buddha into the forest and becomes an arahant. Walking back to tell the Teacher, he passes through a village where a wife has just quarreled with her husband and set out for her family's house; she follows close behind the monk, who never once looks at her. The husband catches up, decides the monk has taken her, and beats him badly while she protests that the monk never looked at her or spoke. Back at the monastery, the monks who rub his weals ask whether he got angry. He says he did not, and they go to the Buddha to report that he is lying. The Buddha answers that those free of the pollutants have laid down the rod and feel no anger even toward those who strike them. Read the full commentary story.

Lower Salford, Pennsylvania

The Mennonites of the Skippack and Salford, 1777–1778

The Swiss and South German Mennonites who settled the Skippack, Salford and Franconia country north of Philadelphia had in 1725 adopted the Dutch Dordrecht Confession of 1632 as their own; its articles on revenge and on oaths bound them to refuse both the sword and the swearing of oaths. The Revolution tested both. Pennsylvania's Test Act of June 1777 required an oath or affirmation of allegiance and stripped those who refused of many civil rights, and men who would not muster paid fines. The Franconia Conference divided in 1778 when the minister Christian Funk, who argued for paying the war tax, was put out of office. The quotation in the story is from the English translation of the Confession by Joseph F. Sohm, printed with the Martyrs Mirror in 1886. In Franconia practice, ministers were chosen by lot, with a slip of paper hidden in one of several hymnbooks.

In the fall of 1777 the British took Philadelphia, and Washington's army spent the winter at Valley Forge. In January 1778 the Pennsylvania Supreme Executive Council made John Lacey a brigadier general of militia, and his men patrolled the country between the Delaware and the Schuylkill to keep farmers from carrying produce into the occupied city, where the British paid in hard money. On May 1, 1778, British troops surprised Lacey's camp at the Battle of Crooked Billet. The Hunsbergers, Detweiler, the Schlossers and the egg wagon in the story are fictional.

After the story of a certain bhikkhu from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 405). The original. Scripture from the Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), tr. Joseph F. Sohm (1886). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.23

Cause Undetermined

> *For the manes attend the invited Brahmanas, follow them (when they walk) like the wind, and sit near them when they are seated.*
> *— Laws of Manu III.189*

Asa aikla ahe, in the claim file on Juniper Court.

I. Notice of Loss

Prairie State Mutual, Downers Grove office · Monday, September 14, 1987

Claim no. 87-DU-31906 · **Policy** HO-3 · **Insured** Shrikant V. and Vasanti S. Joglekar, 7 Juniper Court, Woodridge, IL · **Taken by** phone, B. Nowak.

Date of loss Sat 9/12/87, approx. 2:30 p.m. **Type** Other. **Description** (**insured's words**) "Five openings. One in the attic gable, one in the front of the roof, one in the back of the roof, one in the basement floor. The fifth one we cannot find." No storm reported in DuPage on 9/12. No fire. No vehicle. No tree. Insured states no one was hurt. Insured asked twice whether the company would need to know who was in the house. Advised adjuster will call.

Assigned D. Hajek, field. **Note** Tarp on roof per insured. Rain forecast Wed.

II. Recorded Statement

Shrikant Joglekar, taken at the kitchen table · Tuesday, September 15

Please state your name and occupation for the tape.

Shrikant Vishnu Joglekar. I am a process engineer at Argonne. Not a scientist. I want that on the tape. I make the equipment do what the scientists drew.

Tell me about Saturday, Mr. Joglekar. Take your time.

Saturday was my father's shraddha. The yearly rite for the dead. He died in Pune last September, on this tithi, this day of the moon, and we could not go. Two tickets were twenty-one hundred dollars and our daughter had just started high school. So this was the first year. My wife had cooked since Thursday. You have to feed Brahmins at a shraddha. The Brahmins eat and the fathers are fed. My mother always had four. My wife wanted four.

Brahmins meaning priests.

Meaning men of that caste who know the rites. In Pune you send a boy down the lane. Here there are perhaps eleven in the whole western suburbs, and in September every one of them is at a wedding in Schaumburg. So Saturday morning she sent me to the mandir. The temple. It is in the old Lutheran church on Seventy-Fifth Street, they bought it in 1984, you have seen it, there is still the cross-shaped window. I went to the office and said to the volunteer, Mr. Pandya, I need four Brahmins for a shraddha today, venerable ones, and he looked in the hall and said, I have four.

And who were they?

Four boys. Seven years old. They had their munja in August, the thread ceremony, all four together on one morning, so now they are Brahmins, technically, with the thread. They were in the hall waiting for the Saturday class. Mr. Pandya said, They are bored, take them, feed them, bring them back by four. I said, Pandya-ji, my wife. He said, They are Brahmins or they are not Brahmins? Which one?

So I took them. They sat in the back of the Oldsmobile with the seat belts across all four, like that. Very quiet boys. One had a Cubs cap. I remember I thought, I will tell her they are the sons of very learned families.

What happened at the house?

You should ask her.

I will. I'm asking you.

She had set the living room. Four good chairs from the dining set, with her shawls over them, the silk ones from our wedding, and four banana leaves we bought frozen on Devon Avenue, and the silver cups. She saw the boys come up the walk and she went into the kitchen and said to me in Marathi, You have brought four little children to feed my father-in-law. Not even old enough to be your grandsons. She took the shawls off the chairs. She put down four of the brown folding stools from the garage, along the wall by the television, and said to them very politely in English, Sit there, please. And they sat. Then she told me, Go back and find me a real Brahmin.

Did you?

I went back and found Dixit-guruji, the head priest, coming out from the noon arati. I said, Guruji, please, my father's shraddha, come. He came. He walked in and saw four boys on garage stools with nothing in front of them and he asked, Have these Brahmins eaten? My wife said, Not yet, Guruji, please sit. He said, They are seated. It was cooked for four. Give me my bag, and he took his bag off the hook and went home.

My wife said, He did not want to eat. He has a stomach. Go and bring another.

So I went for Joshi-buwa. He is a kirtankar from Nashik, visiting for the season, staying in the basement of the Kulkarnis in Naperville. A very famous voice in Maharashtra. He came because he had known my father's name. He looked at the boys and said the same thing as Guruji. Exactly. Have these Brahmins eaten. And took his bag.

You must understand it was after one o'clock by then. The boys had come at nine for class. They had eaten nothing because a Brahmin eats nothing before a shraddha. They were sitting on the stools along the wall with their hands in their laps. Nobody had told them anything. The one in the Cubs cap had taken it off.

My wife said, These swamis do not want to eat with children. Go to the other temple, the South Indian one out by the tollway. Bring one old man. One. With a beard, if possible. I will cook more.

And you went.

I went. In front of that temple there is a bench by the parking lot where the old men sit. Fathers who have come from India to stay with sons and have no car and nothing to do. On the end of the bench, the best end, under the tree, was a very old man in a white dhoti and an old brown cardigan. A white beard to here. I said, Grandfather, it is my father's shraddha, will you come and eat. He said, Yes. He got in the car.

I do not want to say more for the tape.

Mr. Joglekar, the company only needs to know how the openings occurred.

Then the company should ask him.

III. Dispatch Log

Village of Woodridge Police · Saturday, September 12

14:22 911 CALL, 7 JUNIPER CT. FEMALE CALLER SCREAMING, also second female voice (juvenile?) in background. Caller states "a man will not leave, we put him out and he is still sitting." Caller asked if man is armed. Caller states no, he is old. Caller asked if anyone hurt. Caller states "we hit him, he is not hurt, he is waving his hands." Unit 4 dispatched.

14:24 Same caller back on line. States "no assistance needed, we know who he is now." Line disconnected.

14:31 Unit 4 on scene. Spoke w/ RP and husband at door. RP states misunderstanding w/ elderly family guest. Officer did not observe guest. Officer observed four male juveniles seated in living room, approx. 7 yrs, eating. No complaint. Unit 4 clear.

IV. Statement of the Insured

Vasanti Joglekar, handwritten, eleven pages · Wednesday, September 16

MRS. HAJEK, YOU ASKED ME TO WRITE IT BECAUSE I COULD NOT say it into the machine. I will write all of it. My husband is a good man and he left out the part that is mine.

My father-in-law, Appa, I lived with him for nineteen years in Pune before we came here. He taught me to drive a scooter. He ate my food

every day for nineteen years and said every day, Salt is a little less, and every day the salt was correct. When he was dying they phoned us at three in the morning and the line was so bad I could hear the sea in it. We did not go. We had the money, really. We did not go because of tuition and because of the cost and because we told each other next year. So this was the first shraddha, and I thought, this one at least I will do correctly. The book says the fathers come and sit near the Brahmins when they are seated. Appa was going to come and sit in my living room. I wanted to give him the best chairs.

Then my husband brought me four children.

I was so angry I could feel it in my teeth. My mother used to say that kind of anger is like salt thrown on the coals, it spits, and I was spitting. I put the children on the garage stools. I did not give them water. A Brahmin must not take food before the rite but water they can have, and I did not give it, because I did not want them to think they were the Brahmins. That is the thing I did. Nobody did it to me.

Then Guruji came and went, and Joshi-buwa came and went, and both of them said the same words, and I did not hear it. I thought they were insulting my cooking.

The old man came at two. When I opened the door I was so happy. A beard, a dhoti, old, old. Like a man from a picture of my grandfather's village. I took the two good shawls off the chairs and put both on one chair for him, the green and the gold, and I said, Please, Grandfather, sit here.

He walked past the chair. He went to the four boys on the stools and he went down to the carpet in front of them, knees and hands and forehead, the full namaskar, the five limbs on the floor, to children. Seven years old. One by one. The one without the cap started to laugh and then stopped. Then the old man sat down cross-legged on the carpet at the end of the row, lower than the stools, beside the television.

I said to my husband, You have found one old enough to be your father and he is bowing down to boys young enough to be his grandsons. Is he mad? What use is he? Put him out.

My husband took him by the shoulder. Then by the arm. Then around the waist. He could not move him. He is not a big man, Mrs. Hajek, the

old man, he was thin, I could see his ribs through the cardigan, and my husband could not move him. So I took one arm and my husband took the other and we pulled him. I hit him on the back. I want to write that down plainly. I hit an old man on the back with my open hand, twice, three times, and we dragged him across my carpet to the front door and out onto the step, and I shut the door.

When I turned around he was sitting in the living room at the end of the row of boys, cross-legged, exactly where he had been. He was moving his hands in the air a little, back and forth, the way you would wave to a child in a car going away.

Our daughter came down the stairs at that moment and saw him and screamed, and I was already screaming, and I telephoned the police.

Then he told us who he was.

My husband will not say the name to you. I will. It was Indra, the king of the gods, whose seat is in heaven. I do not expect the company to write that on the form. When he said it I saw what he was, for as long as it takes to breathe in, and he had eyes. All over him, the arms, the chest, the cardigan, a thousand eyes, like the little mirrors sewn into my wedding shawl when the lamp is near it, and every one of them was looking at the four boys on the garage stools.

I told the police we did not need them.

Then I served. I put the boys on the dining chairs, all of them, with the shawls, and the old man on the carpet where he wanted to be. I served the rice and the varan and the kheer and the vade and the five vegetables, and the boys ate like boys who had had nothing since the night before, and the old man ate a little. Then I went out on the deck with the rice balls for the crows, which I had put on the railing at noon, and which no crow had come near all morning, though the crows are in every tree on Juniper Court. Mrs. Hajek, they came down while I was standing there. Six of them. One walked up and took the first ball before I was even back inside. I sat down on the deck steps and cried until my daughter came out.

When I went in they were leaving.

I will tell you only what I saw. The first boy went up. Up through the ceiling of the stairwell and the attic and out through the little window in the gable, the louver; you have seen it, the slats are pushed out, not broken in. The second went out through the front of the roof and the third through the back. The fourth one, the smallest, with the Cubs cap in his hand, went down. Through the carpet, through the floor, through the basement floor. There is a hole in the concrete by the furnace you could put a bucket through, and no concrete in the basement, none, no dust. And the old man went out by some way of his own. I did not see. The chain was still on the front door.

I want to say two more things.

The boys were not angry. I watched their faces the whole day. I am a mother and I know a child's anger in the back of the neck. They were hungry, and they were bored, and the small one wanted to laugh, and they were not angry with me for one moment, and that is the thing I cannot sleep for.

The other thing. The book says the fathers come and sit near the Brahmins when they are seated. So Appa came on Saturday. He came all the way. And I put him on a garage stool against the wall by the television, with nothing, not even water, for five hours. And he did not mind. He sat with the boys. Salt is a little less.

Please pay what is correct. I do not need the hole in the basement filled.

V. Estimate

Kowalczyk Roofing & Siding, Lisle · Thursday, September 17

Opening 1. Gable louver, north end. Aluminum slats bent outward along a band approx. 14″ wide. Replace louver, 1 ea. Note: insulation in attic not disturbed. No footprints in insulation.

Opening 2. Front slope, approx. 4 ft below ridge. Round, approx. 14″ dia. Shingles, felt and 1/2″ plywood cut clean, no splinter, no debris on roof or in attic below. Patch decking, felt, 1 bundle 3-tab, brown blend (match not guaranteed).

Opening 3. Rear slope, same, approx. 14″. Same.
Opening 4. Basement floor slab by furnace. Round, approx. 14″. Edges smooth as if core-drilled but no slurry, no cuttings, no dust. Depth not determined; flashlight shows clay. Customer declines repair. Recommend plywood cover for safety. Not our work, refer to concrete contractor.
Opening 5. None found. Checked chimney, plumbing vents, ridge vent, soffits, dryer vent, crawl access. Nothing.
Total $612.40. **Remarks** 23 yrs in this business. Never seen a hole without a mess.

VI. Letter

Vasudha Phadke, graduate student, University of Chicago · Monday, September 21

Dear Mrs. Hajek,

Mr. Pandya at the temple gave me your number and said you would like a statement from the boys, since they were present. Their parents have asked me to answer for them, because I teach the Saturday class and they are seven. I am a graduate student, not a priest. I teach the boys their sandhya, their morning and evening prayers, how to say them and roughly what they mean. I can tell you what they told me and what happened at class.

They came back to the hall at ten past four. Their names are Aniket, Mihir, Rohan and Sameer. Sameer had a Cubs cap. They were fed and happy and a little sleepy. They did not seem to think anything unusual had happened, except that the lady had given them the dining chairs after a while, and the kheer was very good, and an old man had bowed to them, which they found funny.

The older boys in the class, who are twelve and thirteen, had heard by then from somebody's mother about the stools, and the five hours, and the two priests walking out. They asked the little ones, Weren't you mad at her? And all four said no. And the older boys came to me together and said, Vasudha-tai, they are lying. Anybody would be mad. Five hours on a garage stool, no water. They are only saying it because a Brahmin is not supposed to get angry, and that makes it a lie on top of the anger.

I should tell you that I am the wrong person to have answered them. The book I teach from, which their fathers would like them to respect, would not have let a woman teach them anything, and I have had to make my peace with that sentence by sentence. But I have read it closely for six years and I know where things are in it. So I sat them down, the big ones, and I read them two places.

The first was about age. The old Brahmins in the book grew angry once because a young boy named Kavi had taught them and called them little sons, and they went to the gods to complain, and the gods said the child had spoken correctly. And then a little after that:

> *A man is not therefore (considered) venerable because his head is gray; him who, though young, has learned the Veda, the gods consider to be venerable.*
>
> *— Laws of Manu II.156, tr. Georg Bühler (1886)*

The second is from the chapter for the man who has left everything and goes about with a bowl. I told them it was the hardest instruction in the book and that I had never once in my life managed it for a whole day.

> *Let him patiently bear hard words, let him not insult anybody, and let him not become anybody's enemy for the sake of this (perishable) body.*
>
> *Against an angry man let him not in return show anger, let him bless when he is cursed …*
>
> *— Laws of Manu VI.47–48, tr. Georg Bühler (1886)*

I said, You think it is a rule they are obeying, so they must be lying about the anger underneath. It is not a rule for them. Look at them. They are not holding anything down. There is nothing there to hold. That is what the verse is describing, a person it is simply true of, and you have never met one, and neither have I, and now four of them are sitting in the back of this hall eating Mrs. Joglekar's vade out of a foil pan, and you would rather call them liars. That is all right. I would have too, at thirteen.

The one called Rohan asked me afterward why the old man bowed to them. I said I thought he had been waiting a long time for somebody to bow to. He said, In the Cubs cap? I said, Especially in the Cubs cap.

I am sorry I cannot help you with the cause of loss.

Sincerely, Vasudha Phadke

VII. Adjuster's Diary

D. Hajek, field · September 14 – October 9

9/14 Inspected. Four openings as reported, all approx. same diameter. No point of entry, no tool marks. Insured (wife) very quiet, offered tea, then food, then a container of food to take home. Accepted the tea.

9/15 Recorded stmt husband. Will not identify elderly guest for tape. States "the company should ask him."

9/16 Rec'd handwritten stmt wife, 11 pp. Read twice. Placed in file.

9/17 Roofer est. $612.40. Basement slab excluded at insured's request. Discussed w/ supervisor (Kearney) whether Opening 4 is earth movement under the exclusion. Kearney: "Did the earth move or did something go into it?" Could not answer. Kearney: pay the roof.

9/18 Neighbor at 5 Juniper Ct (Mrs. R. Lindgren, 71) states she was weeding at approx. 2:45 on 9/12 and saw "three little boys go up off that roof like kids off a diving board" and assumed it was something for school. Did not see a fourth. Did not see an old man. Asked if she thought it was strange. "Honey, it's Woodridge. They built half of it in a year."

9/21 Rec'd letter from the boys' teacher, U of C. No help on cause. Kept in file.

9/24 Draft issued $612.40 less $250 deductible. Cause of loss: undetermined.

10/9 Reinspected after repair per supervisor. Patches on front and rear slopes visible from street; the new brown does not match after one summer, roofer was right. Basement opening covered with a square of plywood with a brick on it. Insured (wife) lifted the plywood to show me. Clay, dark, a smell like after rain. She puts the plywood back the way you

would cover a pot. On the deck railing, a steel plate with rice on it. Counted eleven crows on the ridge of the house when I came out, sitting right along the line between the old shingles and the new, facing the street. Insured says they have come every day since the twelfth. Says she feeds them first now, before the family. Did not ask why. File closed.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who is tolerant with the intolerant, mild with fault-finders, and free from passion among the passionate.*
>
> Dhammapada 406, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a brahmin's wife cooks for four venerable brahmins and sends her husband to the monastery to fetch them; he is given four seven-year-old novices who are already arahants, Saṁkicca, Paṇḍita, Sopāka and Revata. Furious, she sets them on low seats and sends him for elders. Sāriputta comes, sees the novices unfed, says they ought to be fed first, and leaves with his bowl; Mahā Moggallāna does the same. The husband then brings an old brahmin from another sect, who is Sakka, king of the gods, in disguise. He bows to the novices with the five limbs and sits on the ground beside them; the couple beat him and drag him out, but he is still sitting in the same place. When he makes himself known, they serve the meal, and the four novices leave through the gable, the front and back of the roof and the earth, while Sakka goes another way; the place is called the House with the Five Openings. The monks doubt that the novices felt no anger, and the Buddha answers with the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Indra, the god Buddhists call Sakka.

Woodridge, Illinois

A shraddha in the western suburbs, 1987

A shraddha is the Hindu rite for dead ancestors, held on the anniversary of a death by the lunar calendar and in the fortnight of the ancestors each year. In many families invited brahmins are fed as the ancestors' guests, and rice balls (pinda) are set out for crows; a crow taking the offering is widely read as a sign that the ancestor is satisfied. A boy of a brahmin family becomes eligible to take part in rites after his upanayana, the sacred-thread ceremony, called munj in Marathi; the Laws of Manu set the brahmin boy's initiation in the eighth year after conception, so a newly initiated boy is often seven. Manu's chapters on the student and on the shraddha (II and III) supply the scripture of the story, in Georg Bühler's translation for the Sacred Books of the East (1886), with its well-known lines on caste and on women that the teacher in the story has to read past.

Indian immigration to the United States grew quickly after the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 ended national-origin quotas, and many of the engineers, doctors and scientists who came settled in suburbs such as Woodridge in DuPage County, near Argonne National Laboratory and the research corridor along the East-West Tollway. Through the 1970s and 1980s these families built their first temples in houses and in churches bought from shrinking congregations, and the Hindu Temple of Greater Chicago, which had met in homes and rented halls in Downers Grove and Romeoville, opened its temple at Lemont in July 1986. The temple, the Joglekars, the boys and their teacher in the story are fictional.

After the story of the four novices from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 406). The original. Scripture from the Laws of Manu, tr. Georg Bühler (Sacred Books of the East, vol. 25, 1886). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.24

No Guile

Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile!
— John 1:47

Now this is how I heard it, in the barbershop on Depot Street.

I. The Count

The grove on the Tombigbee · August 1959

By Monday the men in the grove had told it to each other so many times that it had worn smooth, like a step. They told it at the well in the morning, filling the buckets. They told it walking into Caddo Springs with their tin pails, two by two, along the sand road. They told it at night by the fire on the riverbank, where Brother Sutton was not, because Brother Sutton had walked up to Demopolis on Sunday to sit with a dying man and had not come back.

They told it about Wayland.

Put him out, said the man from Sumter County, whose name was Ike Walley, and who had sharecropped cotton for thirty years for a man who once docked him a week for a broken hoe handle. *His own brother. Walked him out past the last row like you'd walk a dog off to shoot it.*

He wasn't ugly about it, somebody said.

That's what I'm saying. That's worse.

The veteran, Royce Pettaway, who had been at the Chosin Reservoir and did not sleep, said nothing for a long time, and then said the thing they had all been coming around to. *Doctor asked him how many. He said forty-nine. Little was standing at the well with a bucket in his hand, fifty feet off. Forty-nine.*

The white boy from Mobile, Dale, with the burn scars up both arms, said he had seen Wayland's face Saturday night at the doctor's table, when Brother Sutton looked down the benches and said *Little* instead of anybody else. He said he had seen a face like that once, on a man at the shipyard watching another man get the foreman job. Two or three of the others nodded. They had seen it too.

Mr. Teague, who had been the worst drunk in Marengo County and was now nothing at all, which he said was better, poked the fire and said it in the slow, reasonable way he said everything now, as if he were reading it off a sign.

Well. It just goes to show. You can come out here and give up your name and your money and your liquor and your wife, and sit under these trees till you're forty, and it's still in there. A man gets mean. Even the best one we got. It's still in there somewhere.

Nobody said it wasn't.

Wayland was on the other side of the fire with the roll book on his knee, writing down who would walk which road in the morning. He heard every word of it. Everybody knew he heard. He finished the list, and tore it out, and tacked it to the pecan by the well where it always went, and went to bed.

II. The Back Doors

Caddo Springs · the same week

It went into town with them. That was how things went in Caddo Springs; you could not set a word down on the sand road without it walking itself up to Depot Street by noon. Marcus Coleman, who was eleven and had seen the grove full of men and had not slept right since, told it in the barbershop on Depot Street on Tuesday, the part about the grove and the part about the gate, and when the barber asked him why Little had not been at the supper in the first place, he told that too. By Wednesday the women at Mount Pisgah knew it. By Wednesday night it had gone up the hill.

Wayland walked his road every morning that week, the same as always, the road he had set for himself, which was the long one, out past the gin to the Negro quarter by the tracks and then up the back alley behind the big houses on the hill. He stood at back doors with his tin pail and his eyes on the ground and took what people gave, and said thank you either way, the way Brother Sutton had taught them. Some doors gave him the same as always. Some doors that had always given him something gave him nothing that week, and looked at him a while through the screen first, so that he would know it was not for lack of biscuits.

He said thank you either way.

On Thursday he came up the alley to the kitchen door of the Pruett house, where Hattie Greer had cooked for thirty-eight years, and where for three years she had put something in his pail every morning without being asked: a biscuit and a piece of side meat, a jar of figs, a cold sweet potato wrapped in a napkin with his initials sewn in the corner because she had sewn them. She came to the screen. She was drying her hands on her apron. She looked at him through the wire for a long time, the boy she had taken up the carriage house stairs at thirteen years old in the dark and fed, the boy whose sums she had checked by lamplight because his grandfather only came on Sundays.

Morning, Miss Hattie.

She did not open the screen. She did not say anything at all. After a while she turned around and went back to the stove, and he stood at the bottom step with his pail a decent minute, the way you are supposed to, and then he said *Thank you, Miss Hattie,* to the screen, in the same voice he had always said it, and went on up the alley.

She heard him say it. She stood at the stove with her back to the door and her hand on the handle of a skillet that had nothing in it, and she did not turn around, and she was angrier at him for that than for anything.

III. The Face

The grove · the same week

Here is what Wayland knew, and did not say, because nobody asked him, and because a man who stands up to explain himself has already started to tell a story about himself, and he had come out to the grove to stop doing that.

He knew he had watched his brother for four months with the lily verse. He had heard him at the well and in the outhouse and walking the sand road and in his sleep, saying the first two lines and losing the second two, every day, over and over, like a man bailing a boat with a sieve. He had watched it wear Little down. He had seen him stop eating. He had seen him sit at the back during Brother Sutton's talks with his hands between his knees and his face shut, a boy who could name every bird on the river by the sound of its wings, being made to feel stupid every day by the one thing in the world he loved. Wayland knew, because he had been out to the grove three years and had watched men come and go, that a man can sit under the pecans until he dies and get nothing out of it but sore knees and shame, and that the shame is worse than the drinking it replaced. He had seen two men go back to the bottle from it. He did not intend to see his brother go.

And he knew there were men in town who would have given anything for the place Little was taking up. That was true too. A man had come out from Linden in July and stood at the gate two days and been turned away because there was no room under the trees.

So he had walked Little out past the last row and said it. He had not been angry. He had looked inside himself for anger beforehand, carefully, the way Brother Sutton taught them to look, the way you look under a house for a snake, and there had not been any there. There had been something heavy, like a sack of feed carried a long way, and he had set it down.

Then the doctor had asked how many, and he had said forty-nine, because it was true. He had already taken Little off the roll. He did not keep a roll that said a thing that was not so.

And then Saturday night, under the doctor's bulbs, Brother Sutton had looked down the table and said *Little,* and Little had stood up and said the lily verse, all four lines, and kept going.

Wayland had felt it in his face before he knew what it was. It had felt like a cramp. It was the feeling of having held one end of something heavy for four months, for a whole spring and summer, and of feeling the other end lifted, all at once, by somebody else. It was so strong it hurt. He had not known what his face was doing. He had found out afterward, from the way the men looked at him.

All week he heard what they said it was. Each time, he turned around inside himself and looked again, honestly, the way you go back to check a stove you know good and well you turned off. Each time there was nothing there but the stove, cold. He did not hold it against them that they saw something else. He would have seen something else too, if it had been somebody else's face. He kept the roll and set the roads and walked the long one himself every morning and said thank you at the back doors, and what they said about him came down on him all week like dust on a hat, and he brushed it off at night without thinking about it, and in the morning there was more, and he brushed that off too.

Little did not take part. He was the only one in the grove who did not. When the men started in at the well he would pick up his bucket and go, and once, when Ike Walley said something about Wayland to his face, expecting to be thanked for it, Little looked at him the way he looked at a bird he had not seen before, and said, *Mr. Ike, I don't believe you know my brother,* and went off down to the river. He still had the handkerchief in his shirt pocket, folded square, grey as a mule's flank. He had not washed it.

IV. The Needle

The Pruett kitchen · Friday morning

Brother Sutton came back from Demopolis on Thursday night, and Friday morning he walked into town with his tin pail like any

OTHER MAN, AND HIS ROAD THAT DAY, FOR NO REASON ANYbody could see, took him up the alley to the Pruett kitchen.

Hattie Greer was putting up pickles. It was the time of year for it. There were cucumbers soaking in a crock of brine on the floor, and quart jars in a row on the table, and a bowl of little yellow mustard seed, and dill, and garlic, and the whole kitchen smelled of vinegar coming to a boil. She had a needle stuck in the front of her apron, because she had been letting out the seam in Mrs. Pruett's housedress between batches, and she was in no humor for anybody.

She opened the screen for him. She would not have opened it for anybody else from the grove that week. She put a biscuit in his pail with more force than a biscuit needs.

You come about Wayland, she said.

I come for breakfast, said Sutton. *But go ahead.*

She went ahead. She told him about carrying the two of them up the carriage house stairs in 1952 with paper tags pinned to their jackets. She told him about Little's wandering sums and the old man setting the tablet down like it might break. She told him about the eleven dollars she had given Little a nickel at a time for seven years, against the day, and how the day had come, and it was his own brother brought it. She told him she had raised that boy Wayland and she did not know where he had learned to be so cold, because it was not from her. She was crying by the end, the way she did everything, without any noise.

Sutton heard all of it. Then he reached over and took the needle out of the front of her apron, gently, the way you take a splinter out of a child, and held it up between his thumb and his finger with the point to the ceiling. With his other hand he picked one mustard seed out of the bowl on the table and set it on the point of the needle.

It fell off. It ticked on the oilcloth and rolled.

He set another one on the point. It fell off.

Try it, he said, and held the needle out.

Hattie looked at him like he had lost his mind. Then, because she had a habit of doing what was in front of her, she took the needle and a seed and tried. She had threaded ten thousand needles in her life by lamplight

with her eyes half shut. She set that seed on the point as careful as she had ever done anything. It sat for no time at all. It fell off.

That's that boy, Sutton said. *You can set anything you want on him. Mean. Proud. Jealous. Cold. I been watching three years. It don't stay. There's nothing on him for it to hold to.* He took his pail off the table. *He did what he did for his brother, Miss Hattie. Not against him. He put the thing first that ought to come first, and he put himself last behind it, and his brother right behind himself. That's all it was.*

He went out the screen door and down the step. Hattie stood at the table with the needle in her hand. On the oilcloth in front of her there were three mustard seeds, small and round and yellow, and she looked at them for a long time while the vinegar boiled over on the stove behind her and hissed in the burner and filled the kitchen with steam.

V. The Fire

The riverbank · Friday night

That night by the fire they started in on it again, because it had become the thing they did by the fire, the way some men whittle. Ike Walley said it. Dale said it. Mr. Teague said his piece about how it is still in there, even in the best one, and Royce Pettaway said forty-nine. Wayland was not there. He had walked out to the Mabry gate after supper to sit with the man from Linden, who had come back and was sleeping by the road, to tell him there was a place for him now.

Brother Sutton came down from his cot and stood at the edge of the firelight with his hands in his pockets, and they did not hear him until he spoke.

What are y'all sitting here talking about?

They told him. It took a while, because they each told their part, and they had had a week to get good at it. He listened to the whole thing with his head a little to one side, the way he listened to everything, as if it were music from a long way off and he was trying to make out the tune.

No, he said, when they were done.

It was quiet enough to hear the river.

That man doesn't have it in him, Sutton said. *Not mean, not proud, not jealous. Not the thing you saw on his face Saturday either, Dale. I saw his face too. I was looking right at it. You saw a man getting passed over. I saw a man that had been carrying a load uphill by himself since April and just felt somebody take the other end. That's all that was.*

He put his own brother out, Ike Walley said. *I heard him.*

He did. And he'd do it again. He put that boy out because he put the teaching in front of everything, his brother and himself both, and he loved his brother enough to say it to his face and take what come of it. You think that's easy? You try it. You go up the hill tomorrow and tell somebody you love the plain truth about theirself, with no meanness in it, and walk away, and let the whole county call you cold for a week, and say thank you at every back door that shuts on you. You try it and see what's in you.

Nobody said anything. Mr. Teague looked into the fire.

There's a place in John, Sutton said, after a while, quieter, *where they bring a man to Jesus that hadn't done a thing yet. Hadn't preached, hadn't healed nobody, hadn't said hardly a word. Just a man walking up. And Jesus looked at him coming, and said this.*

> *Jesus saw Nathanael coming to him, and saith of him, Behold an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile!*
>
> *— John 1:47*

That's all, he said. *No guile. Nothing hid. Nothing in there for it to catch on. You can know a man like that by the way he walks up to you. I knew Wayland Reed the first Sunday he walked into this grove, at seventeen, and sat down at the back, and listened, and asked me could he stay. I knew it then.*

He stood a while longer. Then he said goodnight to them and went back up toward his cot, and halfway there he turned around, as if he had forgotten something.

Royce, he said. *How many are we tonight?*

Royce Pettaway looked around the fire, and out at the dark under the pecans where the cots were, and up at the gate.

Fifty-one, he said. *Counting the new man from Linden that Wayland went out to fetch.*

That's right, said Sutton, and went to bed.

• • •

Hattie Greer did not say anything to anybody about the needle. But on Saturday morning, when Wayland came up the alley with his pail, the screen door was already open and propped with a brick, and there was a plate on the step with a napkin over it, and on the napkin, in the corner, his initials, which she had sewn there herself in 1953, in blue thread. He ate on the step. When he brought the plate in she was at the stove with her back to him, and she did not turn around, and she said, to the skillet, *Charity suffereth long,* and he said, *Yes ma'am,* and she said, *Is not easily provoked,* and he said, *No ma'am, I don't guess it is,* and she said, *Well, go on, then,* and he went on.

VI. The Roll

The grove · 1983

The reporter from Birmingham came down in the spring of 1983, twenty-four years later, because Marcus Coleman, who was a doctor himself by then, with his father's practice on Hackberry Street, had told him the story of the full grove over a long lunch at a medical meeting, and the reporter had thought it would make a Sunday feature. He drove out to the Mabry place in a rented Chevrolet. Brother Sutton had been dead nine years and was buried at the edge of the pecans under a fieldstone with nothing on it. Little Reed talked to the men under the trees in the afternoons now, and there were seventy of them, and people came from as far as Atlanta to sit at the back. Little would not talk to the reporter about himself. He said he did not have anything to say about himself that the reporter would find interesting, and went down to the river.

So the reporter talked to Wayland. Wayland was forty-four. He still kept the roll and set the roads, and he still walked the long one himself

every morning with a tin pail, out past where the gin had been to the houses by the tracks and up the back alleys on the hill, where some of the back doors were opened now by the grandchildren of the people who had opened them in 1959, and some of the big houses had been sold to people from Mobile who did not know what the pail was for and gave him money, which he gave to somebody else.

The reporter had heard the whole story from Marcus. He asked the question he had driven down from Birmingham to ask.

Is it true you put your brother out?

Yes sir.

Were you jealous of him?

Wayland thought about it. He thought about it for so long that the reporter shifted on the bench. Then he shook his head.

I'd like to tell you I was, he said. *It'd make you a better story. But I've looked. I've been looking twenty-four years. It isn't there.*

The reporter asked to see the roll. Wayland went and got it, a stack of black ledger books tied with twine, one for each year, kept in a lard can against the damp. He untied the one for 1959 and opened it on the bench between them to the second week of August.

Down the page, in a neat schoolboy hand, ran the names, fifty of them, and the roads each man walked. One name had a single line ruled through it, clean, with a straightedge: *Reed, Little.* At the bottom of the column, the count: *49.* And then, under it, a day later, in the same hand, the same ink, the line through the name left exactly where it was, so that anybody could read what had been there and what had been done: the count written again. *50.*

The reporter turned the pages forward, and back. Twenty-four years of ledgers. He could not find another correction in any of them.

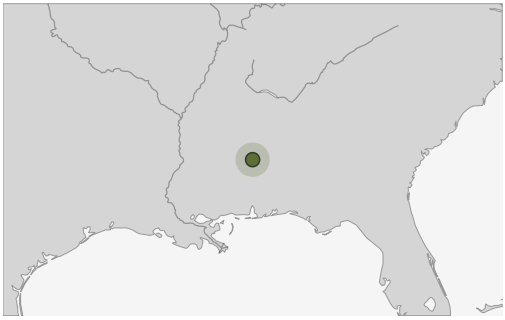
He did not print the story. He told people afterward he could not figure out how to make it come out right. He kept the picture he took, though, which was of the open book on the bench in the shade, with a man's hand flat beside it, and on the page, if you looked close, a mustard seed somebody had pressed there to mark the place, long ago, gone flat and brown in the crease.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana from whom anger and hatred, pride and envy have dropt like a mustard seed from the point of a needle.*
>
> Dhammapada 407, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

This is a sequel to Little Wayland (commentary 2.3). In the Dhammapada commentary, the elder Mahā Panthaka expels his younger brother Culla Panthaka from the monastery when, after four months, he still cannot learn a single verse. After Culla Panthaka's sudden awakening, the monks gossip that even a fully awakened elder like Mahā Panthaka must sometimes feel anger. The Buddha corrects them: those who have destroyed the defilements have no anger, and Mahā Panthaka acted only because he put the meaning and the teaching before everything else. Read the full commentary story, or about the two brothers in the wider tradition.



Caddo Springs, Alabama

Alabama, 1959 and 1983

Caddo Springs is fictional, set on the Tombigbee in the western Black Belt, named for its band of rich dark soil, where cotton plantations held the largest numbers of enslaved people. Demopolis and Linden, the real towns mentioned, are in Marengo County; Demopolis stands on the Tombigbee. Royce Pettaway, the veteran, fought at the Chosin Reservoir in Korea in the winter of 1950, two years after President Truman's Executive Order 9981 ordered the desegregation of the armed forces, a change carried out largely during the Korean War.

The men of the grove go out each morning with tin pails and stand silent at back doors, as Buddhist monks go on the alms round; in 1950s Alabama the back door was also the door of segregation, where Black visitors were expected to call at white homes. The scripture Hattie Greer quotes at the stove is 1 Corinthians 13:4–5 in the

King James Version: "Charity suffereth long, and is kind … is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil."

After the story of the elder Mahā Panthaka from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 407). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.25

Sinners Welcome

Angry words! O let them never
From the tongue unbridled slip.
— H. R. Palmer, "Angry Words" (1867)

The way I heard it told, along Highway 33.

I. Sinner

Oak View, California · March 2019

WALT COMBS CALLED EVERYBODY SINNER. *MORNING, SINNER,* TO the crew coming up the drive at seven with their coffee. *Hand me that flat bar, sinner. Watch your feet there, sinner, that's a nail.* He said it to the driver from the lumberyard in Ventura and to the county inspector who came out to sign off on a set of steps. He said it to the young pastor. He said it to the pastor's wife when she brought sandwiches up at noon in a cardboard flat: *Thank you, sinner, these look good.* He said it to his blue heeler, Buck, who rode to every job on the passenger side of the truck, and to his worm-drive saw when it bound in wet wood. He was eighty-four years old. He had been a finish carpenter in Ventura County since 1958, a good deal of the staircase between Ventura and Ojai was his, and you could not get a thumbnail into a single joint of it.

The Tuesday crew had been going out from the little Presbyterian church off Highway 33 every week since the Thomas Fire. There were six of them that spring, all retired. They did the jobs too small for a contractor to drive out for and too odd for the insurance to pay for: a ramp, steps up to a trailer door, a fence to keep a neighbor's horses off a lot where a house used to be, a shed with a lock on it so a woman living in an RV on her own slab had somewhere to keep her tools. The fire had destroyed

more than a thousand buildings a year and a half before, and most of the lots up the canyons still had nothing on them but a chimney, a foundation and a trailer with an extension cord running to a power pole.

Joan Ekdahl ran the crew. She was seventy-one. She had been a building inspector for the county for thirty-one years, and there was hardly a contractor in the west county who had not stood beside her at some point while she looked at something of his for a long time with a flashlight and said nothing. She still carried the flashlight, in daylight, in her shirt pocket. Phil Brandt had been a chief in the Seabees at Port Hueneme and said *Can do* to anything you asked him. Linda Haskell had taught third grade in Oak View for thirty years and could hang a door so it swung shut by itself from wherever you let go of it. Ray Ocampo had carried the mail in the Ojai Valley until 2011 and knew every road in it, including the ones that were not on the map. Gary Ostrander was a retired orthodontist from Camarillo who had joined in January with a tool belt so new it creaked.

It was Gary who started counting.

Walt did not mean anything by it. Everybody on the crew who had known him more than a month knew that, and said so, and Gary heard them say it and kept counting anyway. He had come to the crew from a big church in Camarillo where nobody had been called a sinner to his face in twenty years, and he did not like it, and he wrote the number down in a little notebook he kept in his tool belt. Forty-one on the first Tuesday in February. Sixty-three on the second.

In January the first big storm since the mud had come in off the ocean. The river went over its banks down at the mouth and flooded an RV park by the freeway, and up in the canyons every creek that had been a line of dry rocks for two years was suddenly brown and loud. The crew was finishing a set of steps that day for a woman named Dana Whitcomb, in a canyon off 33 above Meiners Oaks, and by three o'clock the creek at the bottom of her road was over the low crossing and still coming up.

Phil told it afterward at the hardware store in Oak View, the same way every time. The water was brown and fast and you could hear rocks knocking along under it. Walt had to get the generator back across to the

truck before dark. He stood at the edge with it in both hands and said *Hold up there, sinner,* the way he'd say it to Buck, and walked across. The water on the uphill side of him stood up against nothing, Phil said, the way it stands against a board you hold down in a ditch, for as long as it took an old man to walk forty feet carrying a generator. Then it came on again behind him and took out the far end of the crossing.

Linda said Phil had been a Seabee and had seen water do a great many things, and maybe he had seen it do that one too. Nobody asked Walt. Walt had already said all he had to say about it, which was *Thank you, sinner,* to the creek.

II. The Ramp

Ojai · March 2019

The second week of March they built a ramp for Mr. Penrose.

He lived in one of the little French-looking cottages at Taormina, beside the Theosophists' grounds on the west side of town, where the roofs flared out at the eaves and there were gas lamps on posts along the lanes. He was eighty-eight. He had fallen in the autumn and come home from the hospital with a walker, and there were three brick steps up to his door that he could no longer manage. The cottage had not burned. He had spent the worst of the fire on a cot at the fairgrounds in Ventura, he told Linda, and come home before Christmas to find it standing, with ash on the windowsills and a dead hummingbird in the birdbath. He had wiped the windowsills and buried the hummingbird and gone on.

Walt called him sinner from the first minute. *Morning, sinner,* when Mr. Penrose opened the door in a cardigan buttoned to the throat. *Mind the cord, sinner. You want the rail on this side or that side, sinner?*

Good morning, Mr. Combs, said Mr. Penrose. *That side, please.*

Gary winced every time. It took two Tuesdays to frame the ramp and deck it and set the rails, and Mr. Penrose sat in a chair in his doorway the whole time and watched them. Every hour or so he went in on his walker and came out with something, a plate of shortbread, a pitcher of water

with a lemon in it. Gary watched him, and watched Walt, and wrote in his notebook. At the end of the second Tuesday, while Walt was loading the truck, Gary went over to the doorway.

I want to apologize for him, Gary said. *He's from another generation. I hope you know he doesn't mean you personally.*

Mr. Penrose looked up at him.

A hundred and twelve times, he said. *I'm afraid I can't help counting. I was a court reporter in Los Angeles for forty years. I took down every word anybody said in a room, and I never learned to stop. A hundred and twelve, and once to the dog.*

Then you heard it.

I heard it. Mr. Penrose folded his hands on the bar of the walker. *On a transcript it would read very badly. I've seen men go to prison on transcripts that read better. But you aren't asking me what's on the transcript.*

I don't follow you.

In the room it was a different word, said Mr. Penrose. *A transcript can't take that down. It's the one thing I never could get onto the paper, in forty years.* He looked across at the truck, where Walt was lifting Buck up onto the seat with both arms, because the dog was eleven and his hips were going. *In the room it sounded like good morning.*

Gary thanked him for the shortbread and went and sat in his car.

III. The Complaint

The fellowship hall · April 2019

Dana Whitcomb's letter came to the church office on a Monday in April. The young pastor printed it out and gave it to Joan, and Joan read it and put it in her shirt pocket behind the flashlight.

Dana's house had burned the first night the fire came over into the canyons, in December of 2017. She had been at work, managing a dental office in Ventura, and by the time she got to the roadblock on 33 they would not let her through, and by morning there was nothing up the canyon to go through to. She had lived in a trailer on the slab for sixteen months. Her insurance company had paid her for the contents and was

still arguing with her about the house. Her husband had moved to Bakersfield in the fall. The crew had built her steps and a deck for the trailer and a shed and part of a fence, seven Tuesdays in all, and Walt had called her sinner on every one of them.

I am grateful, she wrote. *I want to be clear about that. I am not a member of your church and you came anyway, and I'll never forget it. But I have been called a lot of things since the fire, by the insurance company and the county and people who think I should have taken the check and moved to Bakersfield too. I have tried to be a decent person my whole life. I did not lose my house because I was a sinner, and I do not want to be called one on my own land by somebody I didn't ask to come.*

Gary had his notebook. Linda, it turned out, had had a call at home from a woman in Meiners Oaks whose fence they had fixed in the fall. Phil said nothing. Phil had served under chiefs who called everybody a great deal worse.

They met on Tuesday after work in the fellowship hall, at one of the long folding tables, with the coffee urn ticking on the counter. Joan read the letter out loud. Then Gary read his numbers. Then Joan looked down the table to the counter, where Walt was filling a styrofoam cup.

Walt.

He turned around with the cup.

Is it true? You call people sinners?

Yes, ma'am, said Walt. *It's true.*

He did not say anything else. He did not say he was sorry and he did not say he wasn't. He stood there holding the cup to see whether she wanted anything more, and when she didn't, he came and sat down at the end of the table with his hat on his knee.

Joan was quiet for a while. Then she told them about 1958.

She had been nine years old. Her grandmother, who was Swedish Covenant and did not hold with any of it, had taken her one Saturday night to a tent revival on a vacant lot on the Avenue in Ventura, down among the oil derricks, because a person ought to see one once. It was a brown canvas tent with the sides rolled up for the heat, sawdust on the ground, folding chairs, a string of bulbs run off a generator that a tall young man

in a white shirt kept going all night from outside. The preacher was a roughneck from the Avenue field named Ancel Combs, who worked the rigs all week and preached all weekend, and before the meeting he stood at the tent flap and took every person who came in by the hand. The men from the rigs, and their wives. A drunk. A banker's wife from up on the hill, in a hat. Her grandmother. Her.

Come on in, sinner, he said to every one. *Come on in, sinner. Glad you came.*

His daddy said it, Joan said. *His granddaddy said it in Oklahoma when it was still the Territory. Before that it was Kentucky. There was a Combs boy who said it at Cane Ridge in 1801, under the trees, to ten thousand people. I looked it up once. That word has been in that family's mouth for two hundred years. It was in Walt's ear before he had teeth. It isn't something he thinks. It's just where his mouth goes.*

Gary said that didn't make it right.

No, said Joan. *I'm not saying it does. I'm telling you what it is.*

She took the flashlight out of her pocket and set it on the table.

I inspected Walt's work for thirty-one years, she said. *I went in behind his walls more times than I can count. I've opened up stairs he built and looked at the stringers. I've seen his work with the drywall off, and I've seen him with his dog, and I've seen him with a man who stiffed him out of four thousand dollars in 1986, and I'll tell you what I never found. I never found anything in there. A man who's got something mean in him, it comes out somewhere, in the work or the way he talks to the help. I've looked. There's nothing behind that word. A man who's right inside doesn't say things to cut you. He can't. Walt can't. It only sounds like he does.*

Nobody said anything. The urn ticked.

It hurt Dana, Gary said at last.

I know it did, said Joan. *I'll go up and see her.*

Then Linda, who had taught third grade for thirty years and knew when a room needed somebody to say something else, asked Walt whether his daddy had ever preached on anything besides sinners.

Walt thought about it.

He had one he wrote inside the cover of his Bible, he said. *Said he never could live up to it, so he put it where he'd see it every time he opened the book.* And he said it to them from the end of the table, plain, without looking at anything, the way you would read somebody a measurement.

> *Let no corrupt communication proceed out of your mouth, but that which is good to the use of edifying, that it may minister grace unto the hearers.*
>
> *— Ephesians 4:29*

That's the one, Walt said, and drank his coffee.

Gary sat looking at the notebook on the table in front of him. Then he closed it and put it back in the pocket of his tool belt, and as far as anybody knows he never wrote in it again. Linda said later that something happened in the fellowship hall that afternoon that she could not have explained to a parent at conference time. It was like hearing a word you had used all your life spoken in another language, she said, and finding out for the first time what it meant. Phil said he had known it all along. Ray Ocampo, who had not said a word the whole meeting, got up and went to the urn and brought Walt's cup back full without asking, and on his way past he put his hand on the old man's shoulder.

IV. Sinners Welcome

The canyon above Meiners Oaks · May 2019

Joan drove up to Dana's on a Thursday by herself and sat on the new steps and told her. It did not take long. Dana listened with her arms folded and said she didn't know. She said she would think about it. She said she had been raised Catholic in Oxnard and nobody had said the word sinner to her face since her First Confession, and she hadn't liked it then either.

The hills had come back green over the winter, as green as anybody could remember, and in April the wild mustard came up yellow across the whole burn, so thick on the slope behind Dana's slab that you could not

see the black on the oaks unless you went right up to them. The oaks were putting out leaves straight from their trunks, in tufts. By the middle of May the sun on the slab was something you had to get out of before noon.

The crew came up the last Tuesday of the month to finish the fence, and Walt brought a shade.

He had a barn on a lot behind his house in Oak View where he kept things, and in the barn, folded on a pallet under a tarp, was the last of his daddy's tent. The rest of it had gone over lumber piles on job sites for sixty years and worn out a piece at a time. This was the last piece, about twenty feet by twelve, brown canvas gone the color of a paper sack, with grommets down one side. He and Phil set four posts around Dana's picnic table at the edge of the slab and tied it off at the corners. It bellied once in the wind coming up the canyon and pulled tight.

Along one edge, where it had hung as the valance over the door of the tent, there were letters in red barn paint, faded nearly to pink. Dana came out of the trailer when it was up, and stood under it, and read them.

SINNERS WELCOME.

That was Daddy's, said Walt. *Don't mind the writing, sinner. It's good canvas.*

Dana looked at him for a long time. Then she sat down at the picnic table in the shade.

They had the fence finished by two. When the others began loading the trucks she was still sitting there, with the mustard moving on the slope behind her and the light coming brown and soft through the old canvas onto her hands and onto the slab where her kitchen had been. Buck had gone in under the table and lain down across her feet. Walt came over to get him, and stood at the edge of the shade a minute, and then pulled out the bench on the other side and sat down across from her and let the dog sleep.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who utters true speech, instructive and free from harshness, so that he offend no one.*
>
> Dhammapada 408, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the elder Pilindavaccha greets everyone he meets, monks and laypeople alike, with *vasala*, the word for an outcaste: "Come, outcaste! Go, outcaste!" The monks complain to the Buddha, who calls him in and asks whether it is true. "Yes, venerable sir, it is true." The Buddha tells the monks not to take offense. Vaccha has no hatred in him; he was born a brahmin in five hundred lives running, and the word is only the habit of all those lives. One who has rid himself of the defilements never uses words meant to wound. Then he speaks the verse, and many who hear it enter the stream. Other sources call Pilindavaccha the disciple most dear to the gods. Read the full commentary story, the same episode in the Udāna (3.6), or the entry on Pilindavaccha in the *Dictionary of Pāli Proper Names*.

Oak View, California

The Ojai Valley, 2019

The Thomas Fire of December 2017 destroyed more than a thousand structures in Ventura and Santa Barbara counties, among them homes in the canyons along Highway 33 above Ojai. A year and more later, many owners were still living in trailers on their lots while they fought their insurers for the money to rebuild. On January 17, 2019, a winter storm pushed the Ventura River, which is dry most of the year, over its banks near its mouth and flooded an RV park beside the freeway. The Tuesday crew, its church, Dana Whitcomb and the Combs family are invented. Mr. Penrose comes from Fire Year; his cottage is in the Taormina community, built as a retirement colony for Theosophists beside Krotona, with French Norman cottages and gas

lamps along its lanes. The Seabees' home base was the Naval Construction Battalion Center at Port Hueneme.

Walt's word comes a long way. The great revival at Cane Ridge, Kentucky, in 1801, which drew close to ten thousand people, made the outdoor revival a fixture of American Protestant life, and the tent revival carried it into the twentieth century. In the 1930s the Dust Bowl and the Depression brought more than a million "Okie" migrants to California, most of them Baptist, with Methodist and Pentecostal minorities. Some found work in the oil fields; the Ventura Avenue field, in the hills along the river north of Ventura, was among the most productive in the country by the 1950s. Horatio Palmer's Sunday-school hymn "Angry Words" appeared in 1867 and went into more than a hundred hymnals.

After the story of the elder Pilindavaccha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 408). The original. Scripture from the King James Version, with a hymn by H. R. Palmer (1867). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.26

A Sinew's Worth

> *That from the very woof thread unto the shoe latchet, I will not take of any things that are thine.*
> *— Genesis 14:23*

C'est de même que je l'ai entendu, on the Sheyenne.

I. Le Ramasseux

Pembina to the Sheyenne River · September 1847

Isidore was fifteen that fall and belonged to no cart. His mother had died the summer before, and his father he knew only as a name other people remembered. When the hunt went out from Pembina he went with it on foot, behind the last of two hundred carts, in the noise of their dry axles, which a person could hear for half a day's ride across the plain.

A camp on the move sheds like a dog. Something fell off every cart every mile: a linchpin, a child's moccasin, an awl, a tin cup, a twist of tobacco, a strap. Isidore walked at the back and picked it all up. When the guide's flag came down in the evening and the carts drew into their circle with the shafts turned out, he went around the inside of it holding each thing over his head and calling *À qui? À qui ça?* until somebody put out a hand. What nobody claimed by dark he used, or gave to whoever was nearest. His capote had been three men's before it was his. So they called him le Ramasseux, the one who picks up.

He ate at any fire that had room. He cut meat for any woman who handed him a knife. He was not sad, which bothered some people, and he never seemed to be holding anything, which they did not notice until later.

No priest rode with them that fall. Before they left Pembina the captains were chosen, and the soldiers under them, and the crier walked through the camp calling the law of the hunt, as he did before every hunt Isidore could remember. No buffalo run on Sunday. No party to go ahead or fall behind. No man to run before the word. For breaking those, the saddle cut up, then the coat cut off your back, then the whip. And at the end, the one the boys always waited for. For theft, even to the value of a sinew, the thief to be brought to the middle of the camp, and his name cried three times, with the word after it.

II. The Sash

Camp on the Sheyenne · the day after the first run

THEY RAN BUFFALO NINE DAYS OUT, AND THE NEXT MORNING the whole camp was meat. The women had it cut thin as cloth and hung on the racks, with slow fires under, and the smoke and the smell of fat lay over the carts and got into everything.

Narcisse Laframboise was twenty, from White Horse Plain, and owned the best sash on the hunt. It was an Assomption sash, wool, fine as a woman's hair ribbon, red with the arrow pattern down it in blue and white and yellow, and he had been two winters paying for it. He would not have it in that smoke, and he would not have it on him while he worked and take the smell of his own sweat. He carried it fifty steps outside the circle to the creek and hung it on a buffaloberry bush in the clean wind. Then he went and sat behind his cart, facing his tent, to scrape a hide.

Isidore came along the creek with two kettles. He saw a sash on a bush. He looked up the bank and down it and across the water and saw no one.

Another boy would have thought, that is too good to be lost. It did not come into Isidore's head. He had picked up a silver thimble and a broken trace in the same morning, once, and held them up exactly alike. The thing was there and its person was not. He set down the kettles, took the sash off the bush, and started for the carts with it over his head, drawing breath to call.

Voleur!

Narcisse came around the cart with the scraper still in his fist. *That is my sash. You know the law, Ramasseux. Even a sinew.*

It's yours?

Everybody in this camp knows it's mine.

I didn't see anybody. I thought it was left. Here.

He put it in Narcisse's hands and went back for his kettles. Narcisse stood there with a good deal more to say, and the sash, and nobody in front of him.

III. Long or Short

The same evening, at the fires

Isidore told it himself, at the first fire he sat down to, the way he would have told that he had found a cup. The boys his own age had it off him in a minute.

So, Ramasseux. This sash you took. Was it a long one or a short one?

Was it fine or coarse?

Did it have arrows on it? What color? Come on, you had it in your two hands.

I don't know, Isidore said. *Red. Never mind if it was long or short. I thought it was left.*

They howled. There was not a child on the hunt who could not have told you that sash to the thread: the length, twice around Narcisse and down to his knee, the fringe, the blue next to the white. But the older boys did not laugh, and two of the soldiers, who had been listening, did not either.

He's lying, one of them said. *Nobody alive takes that sash off a bush and doesn't look at it. He looked. He wanted it, he took it, and he gave it back because he was caught.*

That was another matter. That was the law, and the middle of the camp, and a name called three times. They got up and went to the captains' fire, and took the boy with them, and Narcisse came, and half the camp behind.

The captains listened and then sent for old Josephte. She said the prayers, evenings and Sundays, when there was no priest. She had baptized on the plains and buried there, and she was who they asked when a thing was not in the law. She came with her shawl over her head and had the boy stand where the light was on him.

What did you pick up today?

A linchpin. That was Gariépy's. An awl. A baby's moccasin, that was at the crossing. A sash.

What was the sash like?

Red.

Long?

I don't know, Grand-mère. I didn't have it long. Then it was his.

She looked at him a while, and then around the fire at the men.

I have watched every one of you look at that sash, she said. *You cannot think how a person could have it in his hand and not measure it. That is how it is with you, and with Narcisse. It is not how it is with him. I have walked in front of this boy since Pembina. Half of what this camp owns has been through his hands, and he has given it back down to the awls. He is telling you the truth. He did not take it, because there is nothing in him that takes.*

Then she said what Abraham swore to the king of Sodom, when the king offered him the goods of the city. She had it by heart out of the old priest's book, the way she had everything.

> *Je lève la main et je jure par le Seigneur, le Dieu très-haut, possesseur du ciel et de la terre, que je ne recevrai rien de tout ce qui est à vous, depuis le moindre fil jusqu'à un cordon de soulier.*
>
> *— Genèse 14:22–23, Bible de Sacy*
>
> *That from the very woof thread unto the shoe latchet, I will not take of any things that are thine.*
>
> *— Genesis 14:23, Douay-Rheims*

From a thread to a moccasin string, she said. *He could swear that to this whole camp, and he is the only one of us who could.*

Nobody's name was cried. The captains said it was finished. Narcisse stood a moment with his hand flat on the knot at his hip, and then he said *Bon,* to no one, and went to his tent. A good many people sat late at the fires that night without much talk, each with whatever he had been two winters paying for.

• • •

In the morning the flag went up and the carts pulled out of the circle, one behind another, and began to scream. Isidore waited for the last of them. By a dead fire he found a length of sinew thread somebody had dropped from her sewing, as long as his arm and no thicker than a grass stem.

He held it up over his head and walked forward along the line. *À qui? À qui ça?*

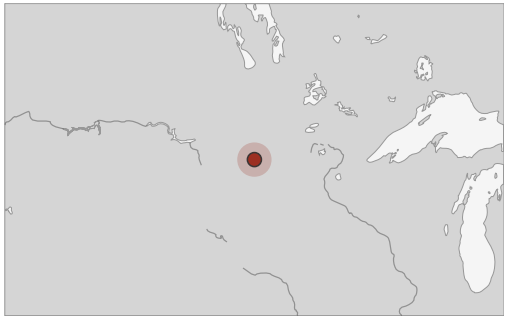
They laughed all the way up the carts. It was old Josephte who put her hand out.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who takes nothing in the world that is not given him, be it long or short, small or large, good or bad.*
>
> Dhammapada 409, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a Brahmin of Sāvatthī takes off his outer cloth so that it will not catch the smell of his body, lays it aside, and sits down facing his house. A monk who is an arahant passes, sees the cloth and no owner, and takes it for a cast-off rag of the kind monks made their robes from. The Brahmin runs up shouting that he is a thief; the monk asks if it is his and hands it back. When he tells the story at the monastery the other monks tease him: was it long or short, coarse or fine? He answers that he has no attachment to it either way, and they report him to the Buddha as a liar. The Buddha says he speaks the truth: those who are free of the pollutants do not take what belongs to others. Read the full commentary story.



Sheyenne River, North Dakota

The Pembina hunt, 1847

Twice a year through the middle of the nineteenth century the Métis of the Red River country, French- and Michif-speaking Catholic families of mixed Indigenous and European descent, gathered at Pembina, just south of the forty-ninth parallel, and went out onto the plains of what is now North Dakota after buffalo. The great hunt of 1840, described by Alexander Ross, counted 1,210 carts and 1,630 people and reached the Sheyenne River nine days out. The hunters elected captains, soldiers and guides; a flag raised in the morning meant march and lowered in the evening meant camp; the Red River carts, built without iron and never greased, were drawn up at night in a circle with the shafts outward. Women cut and dried the meat and made the pemmican.

The laws of the hunt in the story are those recorded for the hunt of 1840, ending with the one on theft: "even to the value of a sinew," the offender was brought to the middle of the camp and the crier called out his or her name three times, adding the word "Thief." Priests rode with some hunts and not others. The arrow sash, the ceinture fléchée, was finger-woven at L'Assomption in Lower Canada, sold through the fur companies, and worn over the blue capote. The autumn hunt of 1847 in the story, and everyone on it, are invented. Lemaître de Sacy's French Bible, made in the seventeenth century, was the most widely read French Catholic translation of the period.

After the story of a certain elder from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 409). The original. Scripture from the Bible de Sacy and the Douay-Rheims Bible. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.27

The Comforters

¡Vida, nada me debes! ¡Vida, estamos en paz!
— Amado Nervo, "En paz"

Así lo oí contar, in the section houses west of Newton.

I. The Crossing

Kesler siding, Harvey County, Kansas · July 1931

The Kesler section was eight miles of the Santa Fe main line west of Newton, double track on crushed rock across wheat country so flat that a man tamping ties at one end of it could see the water tank at the other end, wavering. Don Feliciano Arreola had been its foreman since 1919. He had a gang of eleven men, a motor car that started on the third pull, a tool house, and four old boxcars set off at the end of the siding on short rails of their own, with stovepipes through their roofs and little windows the men had cut with a keyhole saw and hung with flour-sack curtains. The married men lived in three of them with their wives and children. The fourth was the bunk car, where the single men slept, and the boys.

There were five boys that summer. Beto Ochoa was sixteen, and his father Tomás worked on the gang. Nacho Galván was seventeen. Rafa Lomelí said he was sixteen and was fifteen. The two Dávalos cousins, Chuy and Lalo, had come up from Laredo in April with a paper from a labor agent and nothing else. Don Feliciano had put all five in the bunk car with Chencho Bañuelos, who was fifty and snored and had carried a rifle for Obregón, because the boys were a little afraid of Chencho and would not stay out late in Newton.

Harvest came at the end of June. It was the biggest wheat crop Kansas had ever grown, and the trucks and wagons came to the elevators all day and half the night, and the price was thirty-three cents a bushel and going down, which was less than it cost to grow. The farmers hauled it in anyway, because it was in the field.

On the ninth of July, a little after four in the afternoon, a Mennonite farmer named Heinrich Voth stalled his Ford truck on the Kesler crossing with forty bushels of hard red wheat in the box and his wife beside him on the seat. The gang was spiking a joint two hundred yards east. Don Feliciano heard the starter grind, and grind, and stop. Then he heard, far off in the west, the whistle of the eastbound freight, and he said one word, and eleven men ran with their bars.

There was no time to push the truck. They set their lining bars under the frame and the axle, the way they set them under a rail, and Chencho called the count, and they lifted it and walked it sideways off the planks and let it down into the ditch on its own springs while the wheat slid in the box like water. The freight came through a moment after, sixty cars, and the wind of it took Beto's hat. Mrs. Voth had not got down from the cab. She sat with both hands flat on the dashboard and watched the cars go by her window as if she were counting them.

When it was gone the men stood in the ditch wiping their faces. Don Feliciano filled the dipper from the water keg on the motor car and gave it to Rafa first, and then to Lalo, and then to the other boys, and then to the men, and drank last. Mrs. Voth had got down by then. She watched him do it.

She spoke German to her husband and English to the foreman, a careful English with the corners turned up. She asked where the boys slept. He walked her to the bunk car and she looked in at the bunks, which were planks with straw ticks and one army blanket apiece, and she said that in January a boxcar was a cold place.

In January it is a cold place, Don Feliciano said.

Our sewing circle makes comforters, she said. *For the relief. For Russia, for China, for whoever needs. We will make for your boys. For the winter. One each.*

He told her it was not necessary. Her husband had just been offered thirty-three cents for his wheat. She said it was already decided, and she took an elevator ticket out of her apron pocket and wrote on the back of it with a pencil stub, *5 Decken, Kesler, Januar,* and showed it to him, so that it was written.

Don Feliciano took off his hat to her. The men had never seen him do that for anybody but the priest who came out from Newton twice a year and the roadmaster's wife.

II. Night School

The tool house · autumn 1931

Amparo Ledesma came out from Newton on Tuesday and Thursday nights in her brother's Ford. She was twenty-three. She had been born in a section house at Emporia and finished the high school there and two years at the Teachers College before the money ran out, and now she dressed chickens on the line at the Fred Harvey plant on East First Street, eight hours a day, and twice a week she drove eight miles to sit at a plank table in the Kesler tool house under a hanging lantern with any man who wanted his letters. She did it for nothing. She was small and plain and said very little, and the men, who were twice her age and some of them three times, called her Señorita and stood up when she came in.

Don Feliciano came every time. He could read printed Spanish slowly with his finger and he could not write at all. For eighteen years he had signed the Santa Fe's time book with a mark. He sat at the end of the bench with his dinner pail on his knees, both hands around it, as if somebody might need it handed to them. By October he could write FELICIANO in capitals that leaned on one another, and then ARREOLA, which was harder, and he practiced on the backs of the forms the roadmaster sent out.

She taught from whatever there was. A first reader somebody's cousin had brought from Guadalajara. The Santa Fe rule book. Poems cut from *La Prensa,* the San Antonio paper that reached the Ranchito a week late

and went from boxcar to boxcar until it fell apart. One Thursday she brought them a poem of Amado Nervo's, who had been dead twelve years and whom all their mothers had known by heart, the one in which a man near his sunset blesses Life and tells it they are even.

Chencho did not like it. *Even,* he said. *Life owes me plenty. Ask me. I'll give you the list.* The men laughed, and the Señorita let them laugh, and then she had Chencho read the line about the roses out loud with his finger under it, slowly, *cuando planté rosales, coseché siempre rosas,* and he read it and said it was a lie, but a pretty one.

Don Feliciano said nothing. He copied the last line onto the back of a form in his leaning capitals and folded it into his shirt.

The comforters began to come in October. Three came first, on the seat of a farm wagon, because the Voths had sold the truck. They were pieced from old dresses and the backs of worn-out shirts, in squares, and filled with carded wool, and tied every hand's width with a knot of red yarn whose two ends stood up like the ears of a rabbit. Mrs. Voth said the other two would come when the frame was free. There had been a death in the church, and then a wedding, and the frame was needed for both. Don Feliciano gave the three to the youngest, Rafa and Lalo and Beto. Nacho and Chuy would have the next.

The roadmaster came out on the first Monday in November. The Kesler section would be joined to the Halstead section on the first of December, under the Halstead foreman, with seven men. Four would be let go. Don Feliciano could stay on as a laborer, at a laborer's pay, if he liked. He thanked the roadmaster and said he would think about it. That night he told nobody what he thought.

All that fall, families had been leaving the Ranchito in Newton. The county had cut them off relief, and the big companies were saying what they said everywhere that year, that a Mexican would be better off among his own people, and a man from the consulate in Kansas City had sat two days at a table in the back of a grocery on West First taking names for the reduced fare to the border. On Tuesday Don Feliciano rode the local into Newton and gave his name. He was going to his sister in Tangancícuaro. He had not seen her since 1911.

Tomás Ochoa worked it out first, sitting on the bunk-car step with a cigarette. Seven was seven. If the foreman stayed on as a laborer, he was one of the seven, and one of the four was a boy.

III. The Address

The end of November

On his last Sunday he rode into Newton and walked out to the Ledesma house at the edge of the Ranchito to give back the pencil and the tablet. The Señorita would not take them. Her mother put him at the kitchen table and put coffee in his hand, because he would not ask for it, and he sat there two hours with his hat on his knee. Nobody remembered afterward what was said. Her mother said only that it was quiet, and that when he left he bowed to the girl as if she were the priest.

On Monday morning, the last day of the Kesler section, he called Chencho and the boys to the motor car before the whistle. He gave Chencho a page from the tablet. On it, in the leaning capitals, was his sister's name and the name of her street in Tangancícuaro, Michoacán, the first thing he had ever written that was not his own name.

When the señora Voth brings the other two, he said, *take them. Give one to Nacho. Chuy is going with the Emporia extra gang, so send his on to him there, by the express. And if she does not bring them, write and tell me.*

Chencho folded the page in four and put it in his hatband. Rafa asked if Don Feliciano wanted his own comforter back, for the train, because the trains to El Paso were cold. Don Feliciano looked at him a while and said no.

Then he picked up a cardboard suitcase with a strap around it and walked down the ties to the crossing to wait for the local, and the gang went out on the motor car to tamp, and nobody looked back at the crossing, because he had taught them that a man watches the track in front of the car.

IV. What the Señorita Said

The tool house · Thursday night

Seven men came to the night class that Thursday, under the Halstead foreman now, and they were early, and they talked while they waited.

Eighteen years, Chencho said, *and what does he take home? A cardboard suitcase. And still. Send me word about the blankets. What does he want, that I mail him two comforters to Michoacán so he can sell them in the plaza?*

He was always careful with things, said Amador Rentería.

A man doesn't change at the end, said his brother Lino. *Even a good man. At the very end there is still a little something he wants.*

The boys said nothing. Rafa sat on his hands. Tomás Ochoa looked at the floor.

The Señorita came in with the cold, unwound her scarf, and stood a moment at the end of the plank table looking at them, and they all stood up.

What are you talking about?

Chencho told her. He was a soldier and he told it straight, and he was a little ashamed by the end of it.

No, she said. *He doesn't want anything. He was thinking about two people. The señora said she would make five. She wrote it down. It is hers to give, and if nobody is at the crossing to take it, or nobody tells her, she loses the giving of it. He did not want her to lose that. And the boys were promised. It is theirs. That is all he was thinking.*

Then she sat down and took the clipping out of her coat, soft from folding, and put it in front of Chencho, and he read it aloud with his finger under it, slower than he had read it in October.

> *Cierto, a mis lozanías va a seguir el invierno:*
> *¡mas tú no me dijiste que mayo fuese eterno!*
>
> *Amé, fui amado, el sol acarició mi faz.*
> *¡Vida, nada me debes! ¡Vida, estamos en paz!*
>
> *— Amado Nervo, "En paz"*

Winter comes after the green years, the old man had said; you never told me May would last. Life, you owe me nothing. Life, we are even.

Chencho sat with his finger on the last line for a long time. Then he said it was still a lie, and after a while he said, *But not for him,* and the Señorita opened the first reader to where they had left off.

• • •

The other two came in January, after the first big snow, on a bobsled behind the Voths' team, with the Voths' oldest boy driving and a hot brick wrapped in a sack under his feet. They were blue and brown, from a man's suits, and the red knots stood up out of them like the others.

Chencho carried one to Nacho in the bunk car. The other he took into Newton on the local, wrapped in brown paper and tied with twine, and at the Railway Express window in the depot he told the clerk he would write the tag himself. He wrote it slowly with the clerk's pen, in capitals that leaned on one another, CHUY DÁVALOS, SECTION HOUSE, EMPORIA, and the clerk read it back to him twice to be sure.

Then he bought a stamped envelope at the counter, and took the page out of his hatband, and copied the address in Tangancícuaro onto the envelope letter by letter, the way it was written, and inside, on a sheet of the clerk's paper, because the clerk was waiting and he did not know how to write more, he put one word.

LLEGARON.

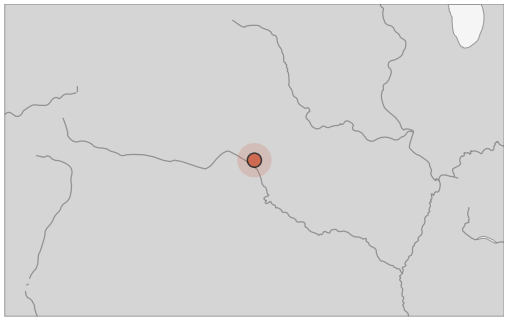
Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who fosters no desires for this world or for the next, has no inclinations, and is unshackled.*
>
> Dhammapada 410, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Elder Sāriputta spends the rains retreat at a monastery with five hundred monks, and the lay people there promise him all the requisites. When the season ends, not everything has come. As he leaves to see the Buddha, he asks

the monks to send on whatever is brought for the young monks and novices, or else to send him word. The monks decide that craving must still be alive in him. The Buddha tells them it is not so: Sāriputta was thinking only that the givers should not lose the merit of their gift, and that the young ones should not lose what was rightly theirs. Read the full commentary story, or about Sāriputta, the disciple who looked after the newly ordained. The commentary tells the same story next of Moggallāna; in this series that is Field Tickets.



Harvey County, Kansas

Harvey County, Kansas, 1931

From the 1910s the Santa Fe and other railroads recruited Mexican men to build and maintain their lines in Kansas, many from Michoacán, Jalisco and Guanajuato, housing them in converted boxcars or shacks beside the tracks. Colonies grew up at the division points, and at Newton the Santa Fe housed Mexican families along West First Street from about 1911, in the neighborhood people called the Ranchito. Harvey County was also the heart of Kansas Mennonite country; Russian Mennonites settled there in the 1870s with the Santa Fe's help and brought hard winter wheat with them. In 1931 Kansas grew the largest wheat crop in its history, 251 million bushels, and the farm price fell to about 33 cents a bushel.

Between 1929 and 1939, most likely somewhere between half a million and a million people of Mexican descent, forty to sixty percent of them American citizens, left or were pushed out of the United States in what is called the Mexican Repatriation, through deportation, relief cuts, pressure from employers and local officials, and cheap train fares to the border; 1931 was the peak year. Many Mexican readers in the United States followed the San Antonio daily La Prensa. Amado Nervo (1870–1919), one of the best-known Mexican poets of his time, wrote "En paz" in 1915. Parcels went by the Railway Express Agency, the express company sixty-nine railroads took over in 1929.

After the story of the Elder Sāriputta from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 410). The original. Verse from Amado Nervo, "En paz" (1915). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.28

Field Tickets

> *Of this volume, only here and there a short chapter has been preserved; and of each page, only here and there a few lines.*
> *— Charles Darwin, On the Origin of Species (1859)*

This is how it was told me, in the bone room at Wakeman College.

I. Sage Creek

The White River Badlands, South Dakota · June and July 1902

Wakeman College sent a party into the Badlands in any summer the trustees could be talked into it, and in 1902 there were five students, a cook, a wagon and team hired from a livery in Rapid City, and Joel Kolb. Kolb was sixty-one. He had driven a wagon for the Yale parties in the seventies, when the Sioux still held the country and the soldiers rode along, and he had collected since for whoever would pay him, and for eleven years now that had been Wakeman, which paid him little and on time. He was big and slow and the color of the clay, and he talked less than the mules.

What he could do was find. In the mornings he walked out alone into the breaks with a canvas bag and a pick and a canteen, and at noon he came back and said there was a turtle on the second bench below the knob with the cap rock on it, and there was a turtle. The boys tried following him and lost him in a quarter of an hour. Ernie Hoag, who was sixteen and from the college's preparatory department and had come along to wash the pans, said he had watched Kolb walk round behind one butte at noon and come out on the far side of the next before Ernie had counted twenty, and that was a quarter mile of ground. Will Dunning, who was a senior and kept notes on everything, said Ernie could not

count. But none of them ever saw Kolb hunting. He walked, and stopped, and there it was, as if he had seen down into the ground.

They camped on Sage Creek under the Wall, where the water was alkali and they hauled their drinking water from a spring two miles up in a barrel. It went to a hundred and ten in the afternoons. When it rained the clay turned to a gumbo that balled on the wagon wheels until they would not turn and on a man's boots until he could not lift them. The beds lay in bands, buff and rose and grey, one above another like the leaves of a book left out in the weather, and every band had its dead in it. There were so many Oreodon skulls in the lower beds that after the first week they stopped taking them unless they were perfect.

Kolb gave each of the boys his own ground and a book of field tickets. Every bone that came out was ticketed where it lay, with a number, the bed, and the name of the one who found it, in the finder's own hand. Kolb would not put his name on a ticket unless he had found the thing and dug it himself, start to finish. *The museum puts on the card what's on the ticket,* he said. It was the longest thing he said that June.

In July, the Bastians' little girl went into the breaks.

The Bastians ran cattle three miles up the creek, out of a sod house and a log barn, Orrin and Hattie and eight children, the youngest a girl of four called Daisy. She went off after a jackrabbit in the middle of the afternoon, and at dusk Mrs. Bastian came down to the camp on a mule without a saddle. The boys and the cook went out with lanterns, calling. Kolb went the other way without one. He came back before moonrise with the child asleep against his shoulder and her fist shut tight on a handful of little white teeth, the teeth of some beast that had been dead longer than anybody at Wakeman would say out loud.

Mrs. Bastian took her and held her and did not say anything for a while. Then she looked at the crates the boys had begun to stack by the wagon, and asked how they meant to get all that to Rapid City. The college had paid for one wagon. The boys' boxes would have to wait on a second.

Orrin will haul them, she said. *After haying. In the big wagon. Every box, no charge.*

Kolb told her there was no call for it. She said there was, and that it was decided, and she said it in front of her husband so that it was said.

Kolb took off his hat. The boys had not seen him take it off since Rapid City.

II. The Skull

Sage Creek · August

In August Kolb found the titanothere. It lay in the lowest beds below a slump, a skull longer than a man's arm with the two blunt horns on the nose, and it took him and Otto Brase nine days to get it out. They trenched round it, hardened the bone with shellac, and wrapped it in strips of gunny sack dipped in plaster of Paris, and when they had turned it over and jacketed the underside it weighed something over eight hundred pounds. It went into the college's wagon with Kolb's own boxes, and filled it.

The boys' crates went up the creek to the Bastians' barn to wait for haying. There were forty-one. Ernie had three, and one of them held a whole turtle, shell and all, that he had found by himself on his own ground and ticketed in his own hand, E. Hoag, No. 112, the first thing he had ever found in his life that nobody had found before him.

A letter came out from the store at the White River crossing with the Bastians' mail. It was from Professor Dalgleish. The trustees met the second week in September, and he wanted the skull in the building before they did, and he wanted Kolb. The boys would finish out the month under Dunning and come home by the railroad.

On the morning he left, Kolb walked the boys up to the Bastians' barn. The crates stood in two rows along the wall with the tickets tacked to their ends. He went along them reading the names.

When Mr. Bastian takes these in, he said to Dunning, *see they go on to the college, every one shipped in the name that's on it. And if he doesn't take them in, write and tell me.*

Then he shook hands with each of them, Ernie last, and climbed up beside the teamster, and the wagon went down the creek with the skull riding in it like a sleeping man under a sheet.

III. The Bone Room

Wakeman, Nebraska · September

The boys came home on the twenty-ninth. The skull was already in the basement under the main hall, which everybody called the bone room, on a bench by the north windows, and Kolb was taking the jacket off it a little at a time with a chisel and a dental pick. The forty-one crates had not come.

Every afternoon at four Kolb put down the pick and walked to the depot and asked the agent whether there was anything from Rapid City. He had written twice to Sage Creek. The boys saw him go and saw him come back, and on the first Saturday in October, with Kolb gone down the hill again, they talked about it over the sorting trays.

Every day, said Dunning. *Every day at four. He wrote Bastian twice. He's afraid they'll come in when he isn't there.*

So would I be, said Frank Ostrom.

That's not it. You heard about Cope and Marsh. Thirty years in this business, a man learns what a bone is worth. I'll bet you he wants to be the one who unpacks them. You know who writes the cards.

We wrote the tickets, said Otto.

In the field. Wait till they're in the cases. A man doesn't change at the end of his life. Even a good one. There's always something he still wants.

Ernie Hoag said nothing. He was washing a tray.

The door at the end of the room opened, and Professor Dalgleish came out of his office with his spectacles pushed up on his forehead. He was seventy-six. He had come out from Edinburgh before the war, and as a student he had been rowed to the rocks at Siccar Point, where Hutton once came by boat and saw what time was, and he had been the college's geologist for thirty-one years, and its whole museum for most of them. He did not often come out of the office. The boys stood up.

What are you talking about, gentlemen?

Dunning told him. He was honest, and he told it all, and by the end he was looking at the floor.

No, said the professor. *Mr. Kolb wants nothing. He was thinking of two things. Mrs. Bastian said her husband would haul your boxes. That is hers to give. If nobody minds it, and nobody tells her it is still wanted, she loses the giving of it. And the boxes are yours. Your names are on them. He would not have you lose what is yours. That is all he was thinking.*

He stood a moment longer. Then he went back into the office and came out with a book, an old one, in brown boards, that had come with him from Edinburgh, and he opened it near the end and read them a little of it in his flat dry voice, the way he read the roll.

> *We have now got to the end of our reasoning; we have no data further to conclude immediately from that which actually is: But we have got enough; we have the satisfaction to find, that in nature there is wisdom, system, and consistency. …*
>
> *The result, therefore, of this physical inquiry is, that we find no vestige of a beginning,—no prospect of an end.*
>
> *— James Hutton, Theory of the Earth (1795)*

He knows where things are, the professor said. *He has never once doubted it, in the eleven years I have known him. He goes to the depot because the agent forgets.*

He closed the book and went back into his office and shut the door.

• • •

The crates came on the fourteenth of October. Orrin Bastian had hauled them in to Rapid City in the big wagon behind the last of his steers, and shipped the steers to Omaha and the crates to Wakeman on the same train, and paid the freight on the crates himself, which nobody had asked him to do. In the lid of the first one there was a note in Mrs. Bastian's hand. Daisy wanted the man who knew where things were to have the teeth back, and they were in a twist of paper underneath.

Kolb unpacked all forty-one himself, that week, every evening after supper, alone. He did not hurry. As each piece came out he copied its field ticket onto a museum card in his slow upright hand, the genus if anyone knew it, the bed, Sage Creek, S.D., 1902, and then the name that was on the ticket.

Ernie's turtle went into the long case by the stairs, on a shelf at the height of a boy's eyes. The card leaning against the shell said *Stylemys. Lower Oreodon beds, Sage Creek. Coll. E. Hoag.*

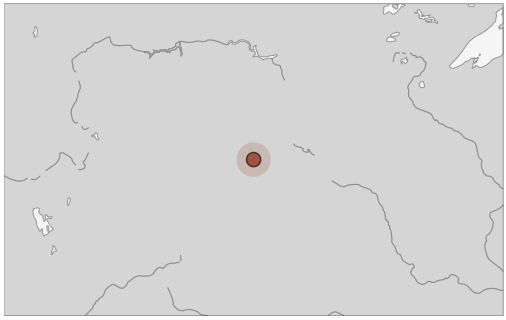
Of all the cards Kolb wrote that October, there was not one with his own name on it. The teeth he kept in his vest pocket, in the twist of paper, until the paper wore through.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has no interests, and when he has understood (the truth), does not say How, how? and who has reached the depth of the Immortal.*
>
> Dhammapada 411, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

This commentary story is told twice, word for word, first of Sāriputta and then of his friend the Elder Mahā Moggallāna. After a rains retreat with five hundred monks, Moggallāna leaves before the promised requisites have all arrived, and asks that whatever comes for the young monks and novices be sent on, or that he be told. The monks take it as a sign of craving. The Buddha says Moggallāna has none: he was only thinking that the donors should not lose their merit and the young monks should not lose their rightful gain. Moggallāna was the disciple foremost in psychic power, remembered for seeing what others could not and going where they could not follow. Read the full commentary story, or about Mahā Moggallāna. Its twin in this series is The Comforters.



White River Badlands, South Dakota

The White River Badlands, 1902

The first scientific description of a Badlands fossil, a jaw from a rhinoceros-like beast brought out by a fur trader, was published in 1846. After that came a long line of collectors: Joseph Leidy described the finds, F. V. Hayden and Yale's O. C. Marsh worked the beds with army escorts, and from the 1870s the Geological Survey, Yale, Princeton, the American Museum, the Carnegie Museum, the University of Nebraska and the South Dakota School of Mines all sent parties, many of them made up of students (National Park Service history). Princeton's summer expeditions, from 1877, chose their students by examination, and in 1890 brought a Menodus skull, one of the titanotheres, out of the Badlands. The land between the White and Cheyenne rivers was opened to settlers in 1890, and ranchers ran cattle along Sage Creek under the long escarpment called the Wall, now in Badlands National Park. Parties outfitted in Rapid City, the nearest railroad town.

The rocks hold the mammals of a lost world: titanotheres with forked horns on the nose, three-toed horses, land tortoises, and so many sheep-sized oreodonts, then called Oreodon, that geologists named the layers in order the Titanotherium beds, the Oreodon beds and the Protoceras beds. The quarrel between Marsh and E. D. Cope over credit for discoveries, the Bone Wars, ended only with their deaths in 1897 and 1899. James Hutton, whose *Theory of the Earth* argued for the immense age of the earth, found what he took for conclusive proof in the tilted rocks he saw from a boat at Siccar Point in 1788.

After the story of the Elder Mahā Moggallāna from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 411). The original. Words from James Hutton, *Theory of the Earth* (1795), and Charles Darwin, *On the Origin of Species* (1859). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.29

Thornapple Hill

> *And truly it was possible, as it were, to behold a land set by itself, filled with piety and justice.*
> *— Athanasius, Life of Antony 44*

Tak ja čul, on the North Side of Endicott.

I. The Capping

Endicott, New York · June 1949

Anna Hrinko had given six children to the Endicott Johnson Corporation's town, and five of them had gone to God. That was how she said it at the counter of her grocery on the North Side, slicing kolbasa for the wives of cutters and lasters: *Five to God.* She did not say it gladly. Her husband had died in the tannery in 1941 and left her the store, the house behind it, a share in the Rusyn burial society, and money in the First National Bank that she did not speak of. Petro, the oldest, had gone first, in 1938, to the Russian monastery in the hills above the Mohawk, and now he was Father Sergius and wrote her twice a year in a hand she did not recognize. The three girls had followed him into the convents one after another, Mary and Olga and Justina, and then John, and then Steve. Every one of them had stood in her kitchen with a cardboard suitcase and said the same thing in the same quiet voice, as if Petro had taught it to them.

Michael was the last. He was seventeen and worked summers at E-J sorting heels, and he was the only one of her children who still came to the store after Mass and ate pirohy standing up at the counter and laughed with the customers. Anna looked at him and saw the store, and the house, and the money in the First National, and the Hrinko name on

the burial-society roll, all of it walking away up the hill with a cardboard suitcase, and she made up her mind. She went to see Mrs. Dzurko, whose husband was a cutter at E-J and whose daughter Helen was seventeen too, and had a face like a plate of cream, and sang in the choir. By Easter it was settled. Nobody asked Michael very much, and Michael, who loved his mother and liked Helen and had never in his life been asked very much, did not object.

They were married on the second Sunday in June at the Russian church, under the crowns, with the priest leading them three times round the table and the choir singing Many Years until the windows rang. Afterward there was the hall on the North Side, three hundred people, a polka band from Binghamton, holubki and pirohy and kolbasa from Anna's own store, and a wedding bread the size of a wagon wheel braided round with dough birds.

Before the bride's dance came the capping. The married women led Helen to a chair in the middle of the floor and lifted off her veil and her wreath, and the oldest woman in the hall came forward on a cane to tie the married woman's kerchief over her hair. That was Helen's grandmother, Baba Varvara Dzurko, who had come from a village in the Lemko hills in 1903 and was ninety-six years old. She had three teeth. Her hands shook so that the knot took her a long time, and her back was bent so far over that she had to look at the bride from under her own brows, and her face was creased like a paper bag that has been folded and folded and opened again. When the kerchief was tied she patted Helen's cheek with a hand like a bundle of twigs, and the women laughed and clapped, and a cousin called out, *Now she looks like Baba!* and old Mr. Dzurko raised his glass and gave the toast that everybody gave:

Look at your grandmother, Helen. God give you to live as long as she has lived.

Michael was standing by the band. He asked the man next to him, a laster from E-J, which one was the grandmother.

Which one? That one. The baba. Tying the kerchief.

He looked at the old woman, and at Helen beside her in the kerchief, and back.

Will she look like that?

The laster laughed. *If God gives her the years, she will. Why not? We all will.*

Michael Hrinko did not dance the bride's dance. He stood by the band with a shot glass he did not drink, and he thought: *So this is what Petro saw.*

At ten o'clock they put the couple in the back of a borrowed Buick to drive them to the house Anna had bought for them on the North Side, with a line of cars behind them blowing their horns, under the arch where the company had put up its Square Deal. On the dark stretch by the river Michael leaned up and asked the driver to stop: he had to go. He went off into the willows and came back. A little way on he asked again, and went, and came back. The third time the cousin who was driving said something rude, and Helen's brother laughed, and they all decided that it was the beer. The fourth time he got out, he leaned in at the window and said, *Go on ahead, it's only up the hill, I'll walk,* and they went on ahead, honking.

He walked out to the highway in his wedding suit with a carnation in the lapel and his mother's gold cross under his shirt, and a milk truck took him as far as Oneonta, and a man going to the Utica market took him the rest.

II. Father Sergius's Brother

The monastery above the Stony Kill, Herkimer County · June 1949

There were thirty monks then at the Monastery of the Dormition. Half of them had come over in the last two years under the Displaced Persons Act, old men who had walked out of the Carpathians ahead of the Red Army and lived four years in camps in Bavaria, and they sat on the bench by the bakery in the sun with their hands on their knees and did not say much in any language. The rest were Americans, sons of miners and shoemakers and steelworkers, who had come up the hill one at a time with cardboard suitcases.

Michael came up the hill at seven in the morning in his wedding suit, which was grey with road dust to the knees, with the carnation brown and the knot of his tie pulled down. Brother Nikolai, who kept the gate, looked at the suit and at the carnation and asked him whether he was lost.

I want to be a monk.

In that suit, you don't look like anybody we would know what to do with. Who sent you?

I'm Petro Hrinko's brother. The youngest.

Nikolai went and asked. He came back with two of the old monks, and none of them knew any Petro Hrinko.

There's no Hrinko here, said Father Pimen.

He's here. Tall. He has a scar on his chin from a sled. You call him Father Sergius.

The monks looked at one another.

You are Father Sergius's brother?

The youngest.

Then come in, quickly, said Nikolai. *He told us. Ten years ago he told us. If my brother Michael ever comes, he said, take him the same hour, and don't send to ask our mother; I am his father now.*

They took the carnation out of his lapel and the gold cross from his neck, and he gave them his wedding ring and his wristwatch and the eleven dollars in his wallet, and they put a black cassock on him that was too short in the arms, and by noon he was sweeping the bakery floor. They wrote to Father Sergius, who was in Pennsylvania that month with the old Archbishop, Vladyka Anatoly, the abbot, visiting the coal-town parishes. Father Sergius went to Vladyka with the letter in his hand and asked leave to go and see his brother. Vladyka read it and gave it back.

Not yet, he said. *Stay with me. We'll go together. Later.*

A week afterward Father Sergius asked again, and was told the same thing.

On the monastery hill, Michael was thinking. His mother knew where Petro was. Sooner or later she would come up that hill in somebody's Hudson with Helen's father and the priest from Endicott, and he did not

know what he would do when she cried. So he went to the old monks on the bench and asked them to teach him how to pray all the way to the end, and they did, an old one and then another, in Rusyn and in Russian and in English that was not very good. Then he asked for an obedience as far from the road as they had.

They had one. A Rusyn bachelor who had come up out of the mines and bought land, dying, had left the monastery his hill farm over in Delaware County, ninety miles south, which nobody had worked since the Depression. The barn had fallen in. The pastures had gone to goldenrod and then to thornapple, which is what the hill people call the hawthorn, a low thick tree with thorns two and three inches long, white and hard as nails, that comes into an old pasture when the cows go out of it and takes the whole hill if it is let. The monks called the place Thornapple Hill. They had meant to sell it.

Brother Michael took a blanket, a prayer rope, a bucksaw, a sack of flour and the Psalter, and walked there.

His mother came up the monastery hill in a Hudson on the twenty-ninth of June, the feast of Peter and Paul, with Mr. Dzurko and the priest. Brother Nikolai met her at the gate and told her the truth, that her son was not there, and that he did not know exactly where in Delaware County the hill was, which was nearly the truth. She cried at the gate for a long time. Nikolai cried too. Then he brought her bread from the bakery, still warm, and she took it.

III. Thornapple Hill

Delaware County · summer and autumn 1949

He lived that summer in the milk house, which still had its roof, and cut his way into the thornapple a few yards a day with the bucksaw, and stacked the cut wood for winter, and prayed. A farmer down the hill named Rhinehart brought him milk in exchange for help at haying and decided after a month that the boy was harmless. The thorns went through his shoes and his cassock and the backs of his hands, and

THE CUTS HEALED AND HE GOT NEW ONES, AND BY AUGUST HE had stopped noticing them.

What else happened to him on that hill nobody could tell. The old monks who heard about it afterward said that before the Dormition fast was out he had come to the end of what they had taught him, and gone on past it, which they said happened sometimes to the young ones, very seldom, and could not be explained, and should not be talked about too much. Rhinehart said only that the boy had got very quiet, and that his own dog, who bit everybody, would lie down across the boy's feet.

He stayed through the winter. Nobody came up the hill but Rhinehart.

IV. The Hill Road

August 1950

IN THE SUMMER OF 1950 FATHER SERGIUS ASKED AGAIN TO GO to his brother, and this time Vladyka Anatoly said, *Yes. We'll all go.*

All was a great many. The Archbishop was eighty, and wherever he went the monks went with him, and wherever the monks went that summer the pilgrims went too, out of every Russian and Rusyn parish from Endicott to Utica: the old women in black who came on foot as far as they could, the shoemakers' families in borrowed cars, a bus from Binghamton and a bus from Johnson City. By the time they gathered at the monastery gate there were five hundred of them, counting the children, and two trucks of camp beds and kettles borrowed from parish halls.

At the bottom of the monastery hill, where the road split, Father Sergius stopped the Archbishop's car and asked which way.

Vladyka, there are two roads. One goes round by the valley, through Cooperstown and Oneonta and every town on the river. It's long, nearly twice as far, but there are people all along it. The other goes straight over the hills by the old turnpike, ninety miles. There's nothing on it. No gas, no towns. The farmers say it's a bad road, and the old women from the Lemko villages say worse than that. They say things walk on it.

The Archbishop looked out of the car window at the column of cars and buses and trucks and walkers behind him.

Is Brother Simeon with us?

He's with us.

Then the hill road.

Brother Simeon was the cellarer, a big soft man of forty from the North Side of Endicott with a voice like a cello and a face like a loaf, and things came to him. Nobody had ever been able to say why. He did not ask for them. When he went down to Herkimer for flour the miller added a sack. When he took the truck to the Utica market the farmers filled the back of it before he could say what he had come for. The old monks said that if Simeon were left alone in the desert of Egypt, a camel would come over the dunes with bread on it, asking for him by name.

So they went over the hills by the old turnpike, ninety miles of gravel and washboard and grades that boiled the bus radiators, through country where the farms had gone back to woods. Nobody walked on the road who should not have. And every few miles, at a crossroads where nobody lived, they found a farm wife standing beside a table under a tree, with milk cans and crocks of butter and bread wrapped in dish towels, or a man with a wagon of sweet corn, or two girls with a washtub of cold spring water and a dipper, and every one of them asked the same thing:

Which one of you is the big monk? Brother Simeon? This is for him.

And Simeon, who had never seen any of them before, thanked them in his cello voice and gave it all to the Archbishop's table, and the Archbishop gave it to everyone, and there was always some left over to put in the trucks. In that way five hundred people crossed ninety miles of empty hills in two days and never once went hungry, on what was given to one fat monk.

V. The Thorns

Thornapple Hill · August and September 1950

THEY CAME UP THE LAST MILE IN THE EVENING, IN A LINE OF headlights, expecting a milk house in a thicket and planning to sleep in the buses.

What the pilgrims found, they told for the rest of their lives on the North Side, and some of them are telling it still. There was a church at the top of the hill, a little one, of new logs, with a blue dome over it and a cross on the dome that caught the last of the light. There were cells down both sides of the pasture, enough for every monk, with a bench outside every door, and long walks mown green between the thornapples, which stood along them like an orchard, and there was a guest house and a kitchen and a well with a roof over it, and room in the barn, which no longer seemed to have fallen in, for every pilgrim and every child. There was a cell at the top of the hill under an old pear tree with a carpet on its floor and an icon corner already lit, and Brother Michael was standing at the door of it in a cassock that fit him now, waiting for the Archbishop.

Father Sergius got down from the car and stood looking at his brother, and then went and put his arms around him, and neither of them said anything that anyone could hear.

How it had been done, the pilgrims did not ask. The farmers down the hill said afterward that there had been no lumber trucks up that road all year, and that Rhinehart had not been near the place since spring. The pilgrims went home after the feast of the Dormition, singing on the buses. The Archbishop and the monks stayed a month.

There were two monks who did not like any of it. Father Pimen and Father Iov were the oldest of the old men from the bench, Carpathian men, who had kept the hours in a monastery in Slovakia for fifty years and in a displaced persons' camp for four, and they sat outside their new cells the first evening and looked at the blue dome and shook their heads.

When does the boy pray? said Father Pimen. *He has been building all year. Look at it. Domes, walks, benches. A carpenter, not a monk.*

And Vladyka comes ninety miles over a bad road and stays a month, said Father Iov, *with a carpenter. Because he is Sergius's little brother. That's all. Favorites, here too, the same as everywhere.*

The Archbishop, who got up at three every morning to read the office and was the first one out of his cell, saw them sitting there before dawn the next day, still with their faces set, and did not say anything to them. He said almost nothing to anybody that whole month.

On the morning they left, in the middle of September, with the haws on the thornapples going red, the Archbishop walked down the hill ahead of the cars, and stopped a little beyond the gate, and stood in the road with his eyes closed, as though he were listening to something far off.

At the top of the hill Father Pimen stopped with one foot on the bus step. *My oil,* he said. *The lamp oil. I left the bottle in the cell.* And Father Iov said, *My kettle. And my galoshes, my good ones, under the bench,* and the two old men went back up through the pasture together, complaining.

They could not find the cells. They could not find the mown walks, or the benches, or the blue dome. There was a milk house, and a fallen barn, and thornapple from one end of the hill to the other, thick and grey and high over their heads, and they went round and round in it with their cassocks catching and the long white thorns going through the sleeves into their arms and through the soles of their shoes into their feet, calling to each other, for most of an hour. The bus driver leaned on his horn. At last, at the edge of the thicket, they came on a thornapple standing by itself, and on its branches, hung neatly by their handles and straps as though somebody had meant them to be seen, were a bottle of lamp oil, a tin kettle and a pair of galoshes.

They took them down without a word and came out bleeding, and got on the bus, and nobody on the bus asked them anything.

VI. Pani Vasko's Table

Endicott · October 1950

Paraska Vasko kept a boardinghouse for Endicott Johnson men on the North Side, three doors from the house Anna Hrinko had bought for a bride and groom who never lived in it, and for thirty years every monk and priest and pilgrim who came through the Southern Tier had eaten at her table. She could not read Russian or English very well, and she had buried a husband and two sons, and she was the cleverest woman on the North Side, which everyone knew and nobody said in front of her.

In October Father Pimen and Father Iov came down to Endicott to collect for the monastery roof, and on their first morning they washed their faces and said, *Let's go to Pani Vasko's and have some soup,* and they went. She sat them down with borshch and bread and asked them, as she asked everybody that fall, whether they had been with Vladyka to Thornapple Hill.

We were.

They say it's beautiful there.

Beautiful? said Father Iov, and showed her the scabs on his wrists. *A pasture full of thorns. An old milk house. A place for crazy people. For hermits.*

That afternoon two of the young monks, Brother Nikolai and Brother Vasyl, came to the door on the same business, and she sat them down at the same table and asked them the same thing.

Pani Vasko, said Nikolai, *I can't tell you. There aren't words in English. It was like the Lavra. It was like Tabor. Like a city.*

Pani Vasko poured their tea and thought about it. The old ones had gone back, she said to herself. Something was forgotten and they went back for it, after Vladyka had gone out of the gate, and they saw one thing. And the young ones saw the place while it was the way it was meant to be seen. She was nearly sure of it. But she said nothing to anyone, and waited.

The Archbishop came down to Endicott himself at the end of the month, for the anniversary of the parish, and on the Sunday afternoon he and Father Sergius and a dozen monks ate at her table, and so did Anna Hrinko, who had not been asked and came anyway and sat at the end without taking off her coat. When they had eaten, Pani Vasko kissed the old man's hand and asked him.

Vladyka, some of your monks say Thornapple Hill is a field of thorns, and some say it's like heaven. Which is it?

The Archbishop looked at her a while, as if he were pleased with her. Then he asked Father Sergius for the book he carried for him, an old English Athanasius with a broken spine that he read to improve his English, and found the page, and had Brother Nikolai read it aloud, because Nikolai had been to high school in Johnson City.

> *So that any one beholding the cells again, and seeing such good order among the monks, would lift up his voice and say, 'How goodly are thy dwellings, O Jacob, and thy tents, O Israel; as shady glens and as a garden by a river; as tents which the Lord hath pitched, and like cedars near waters.'*
>
> *— Athanasius, Life of Antony 44*

Wherever they live, the Archbishop said in Rusyn, to her and to Anna Hrinko at the end of the table, *in a town or out on a hill, among people or among thorns, that place is good. The place is good because of who lives in it.*

Anna Hrinko took off her coat.

VII. The Honey

The same table

Brother Simeon's mother was there too, Mrs. Barna from Squires Avenue, and over the tea somebody asked her, because everyone in the parish had heard about the farm wives on the turnpike, whether Simeon had always been like that.

Always, said Mrs. Barna. *From before he was born. I carried him ten months, and three days he lay crossways, and the midwife went home and said I would die. Then he came, and since then he never once wanted for anything. Why should that be?*

The monks looked at the Archbishop, and the old man put down his glass and told them a story from the Lemko hills, the way the old people told it.

In a village there was a poor man who went one morning to pay his rent to the steward, and on the way, in a lime tree by the road, he found a wild comb of honey. He cut it down, bees and all, and carried it on its branch, meaning to give it to the steward instead of the rent. In the town a servant from the castle stopped him. The count was giving a feast for the bishop the next day, and there was every kind of food, and honey cooked in everything, but no fresh comb, and the count had sent his men out of every gate of the town with money to find some. *What do you want*

for it? the servant said. The poor man saw his coat and asked a crown. The servant said yes. So the poor man asked two, and then ten, and then a hundred, until the servant had his whole purse out. Then the poor man said, *Wait. What do you want it for, that you'll pay a hundred crowns for a honeycomb not worth a kreuzer?* And when he heard it was for the bishop's table, he would not take a coin. *Take it,* he said. *Only let them know it is from me too.* They strained the comb into a silver bowl at the castle and he brought a crock of sour cream and stirred it in, and the bishop and his priests and the count and all the poor at the gate ate from that one bowl, and there was enough for all of them, and some over.

And that, said the Archbishop, *is why everything comes to such a man, wherever he goes.*

But the same man, he said, much later, came to be a great lord, and laid siege to a town that would not give him its keys. Seven years he sat outside its walls, and the people went in and out at night by the little gates to fetch wood and water, and held out. Then his mother sent to him: *You are a fool. Shut the little gates.* He shut them. In seven days the town opened, starving, and gave him everything. For the little gates he paid a long time, and he came into the world with difficulty, and late, and crossways.

And which one was Simeon? said Brother Vasyl.

The old women would say both, said the Archbishop. *The same one as always.* He picked up his glass again. *I say, have some more of Pani Vasko's honey cake. It came to Simeon.*

• • •

Another day that winter, at the monastery, in the warm room by the bakery, the monks were talking about Thornapple Hill again, as they did all that year.

One novice, said Brother Nikolai. *One boy, a year in the habit, and he built a church and cells for thirty monks and room for five hundred. Think of the merit of it. Think what that will count for him.*

The Archbishop had come in behind them with his stick, as he did, so that they only noticed him afterward.

He doesn't count it, he said. *Not the good he did, not the harm. The thorns he cut and the thorns he didn't, his mother's tears and the girl's, all of it. He put it down. He keeps no account.* And he quoted from memory, in his careful English, the place in Athanasius that he had read so often the book fell open there:

> *He at least gave no thought to the past, but day by day, as if he were at the beginning of his discipline, applied greater pains for advancement, often repeating to himself the saying of Paul: 'Forgetting the things which are behind and stretching forward to the things which are before.'*
>
> *— Athanasius, Life of Antony 7*

Helen Dzurko married a cutter from E-J in 1952, after the bishop's court had done what bishops' courts can do, and named her second son Michael, and when she was very old she said that she had never held it against him, that he had looked at her grandmother at the capping as if he were seeing a saint.

On Thornapple Hill, the next May, the hawthorn came into bloom over the whole hill at once, white from the milk house to the woods, and so thick with bees that Rhinehart could hear them from the road. From the road, looking up, nobody could have told whether anyone lived there.

Background

The verses

> *In a hamlet or in a forest, in the deep water or on the dry land, wherever venerable persons (Arhanta) dwell, that place is delightful.*
>
> Dhammapada 98, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who in this world is above good and evil, above the bondage of both, free from grief from sin, and from impurity.*
>
> Dhammapada 412, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

Revata was the youngest brother of Sāriputta. With all their siblings gone into the order, their mother married him off at seven to keep him at home. At the wedding,

hearing the bride blessed with the long life of her 120-year-old grandmother, he saw what age would do and slipped away from the wedding carriage on the pretext of relieving himself, three times and then a fourth. Thirty forest monks ordained him once they understood that his brother was Sāriputta, whom they knew by his monk's name rather than his birth name Upatissa. Revata became an arahat in an acacia forest. When the Buddha came to see him by the short and haunted road, with five hundred monks fed along the way by the merit of the Elder Sīvali, Revata made lodgings for them all by psychic power. Two old monks who grumbled were made to forget their oil, water pot and sandals, went back, and found only thorns, with their things hanging in an acacia. The laywoman Visākhā heard both reports and asked the Buddha, who spoke verse 98; he then told Sīvali's past lives (the honeycomb given for nothing, the siege in which he shut the lesser gates), and spoke verse 412. Read the full commentary story, or about Khadiravaniya Revata, Revata Khadiravaniya, “Revata of the acacia forest.”ldquo;Revata of the acacia forest.Revata Khadiravaniya, “Revata of the acacia forest.”rdquo; The same story is told in this series as Uña de Gato.

Endicott, New York

The Southern Tier and the hills, 1949–1950

Carpatho-Rusyns, from the northern slopes of the Carpathians in what are now Slovakia, Poland and Ukraine, came to America in great numbers before the First World War; by 1920 about 13 percent of all Rusyn Americans lived in New York State, and many worked in mills, mines and factories. In Endicott and Johnson City the Endicott Johnson shoe company employed about 20,000 people under George F. Johnson's “Square Deal,” commemorated on arches over the road, and gave land for churches, including the lots for Endicott's Russian Orthodox parish of Sts. Peter and Paul, organized in 1914. Rusyn weddings kept the old capping of the bride: before the bride's dance her veil was taken off and replaced with the married woman's kerchief or cap.

After the Second World War the Displaced Persons Act of 1948 admitted nearly 400,000 refugees from the camps of Europe by 1952, among them Orthodox clergy and monks who had fled west ahead of the Soviet armies. The hawthorn, also called thornapple and whitethorn, is quick to take over abandoned pasture. The Monastery of the Dormition, Thornapple Hill and the people of the story are invented. Athanasius's *Life of Antony*, the founding book of Christian monasticism, is quoted from H. Ellershaw's translation in the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (1892).

After the story of the Elder Revata from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 98 and 412). The original. Words from Athanasius, *Life of Antony*, tr. H. Ellershaw (1892). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.30

The Cedar Moon

> *The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.*
> *— Matthew 6:22*

I heard it told like this, on the courthouse square in Ransom.

I. Red Cedar

The Llano River country, Texas · 1906

Mr. J. W. Stucky bought cedar posts for a yard in San Antonio, and he was known from the Pedernales to the San Saba as the man who never forgot a name. Before he went up any creek he would stop at the last store and get the names: who lived up there, and his wife's name, and the names of the children in order, and which one had been sick. Then he would drive his buggy up to the door and call the woman by her name, and ask after each child by its own name, and leave a bolt of calico and a sack of candy and a pocketknife for the man of the house, as if he were somebody's uncle come home. The women thought he must be some kin they had forgotten. By the time the man came in from the brakes Mr. Stucky had eaten supper and was sitting on the gallery like he owned it.

That was how he came to know Isom Pace, who chopped cedar on the breaks above the Llano and burned what was left for charcoal. After supper Mr. Stucky asked him, the way he asked every man, whether he had seen anything up in the brakes worth looking at.

Nothing much, Isom said. Some big old cedars in a draw up there. The heart of them is red.

How many?

A good many.

Mr. Stucky went up the draw with him in the morning, and they cut posts out of it for three weeks and freighted them down to San Antonio by the wagonload, and when they parted Mr. Stucky shook his hand and said, *Isom, you come see me in town. And don't bring me anything but that red-hearted cedar. That's the only present I want.* So once or twice a year Isom drove a wagon of red cedar down to the yard, and Mr. Stucky paid him better than he had ever been paid for anything.

The fall Isom was thirty, old Brother Lyle Dobbs died. He had ridden the circuit in that country forty years, through the Indian times and after, and preached under brush arbors to people who had no church, and he was buried at Ransom, on the camp-meeting ground east of town where he had preached every August. The Methodists built an open tabernacle over the ground in his memory, a long roof on cedar posts. Mr. Stucky came up from San Antonio for the dedication with a sack of cedar shavings out of his own mill and walked the length of the grave strewing them, so that the whole ground smelled like the inside of a cedar chest. Isom brought something too. He had sawed a round off the biggest log in the draw, red to the bark, and planed it smooth and oiled it, the size of a dinner plate. He climbed up a ladder and nailed it in the peak of the gable over the tabernacle door. It looked like a moon coming up. People said so.

That was all Isom ever did that anybody remembered.

II. The Light

On the road · 1942 to 1956

His grandson Delmer was born in a cedar camp on the Pedernales in the spring of 1942, and he had a light in him. It came from his navel, round and pale as the moon, about the size of a saucer, and in the dark it shone through his shirt and lit the side of whatever he was next to. His mother said the first night she could have read the Bible by it. The old people in the camp said it was because of the cedar moon. Isom had been dead ten years by then, but they remembered the gable.

His uncle Arlis was a preacher by then, Pentecostal, with a tent. Arlis believed the light came from God. That was the first thing to understand about him. He believed it the way he believed the sun came up, and he also saw, being a man who had been poor all his life, what a light like that would do in a tent. When Delmer was nine his mother let him go on the road with his uncle for the summer, and after that he did not come home except at Christmas.

They had a used Army tent that held three hundred, a generator, two hundred folding chairs and a truckload of sawdust, and a man named Fentress who had sold cemetery lots in Fort Worth and who handled the money in a King Edward cigar box. Arlis preached for an hour on the woman who touched the hem of His garment. Then they turned off the lights. The boy stood up on the platform in the dark in a white shirt, and the light came through the cloth, and the people made a sound Delmer never forgot as long as he lived, a sound like the air going out of the tent all at once.

Then Fentress said what it cost. A dollar to lay your hand on the light. Five dollars for a sick child. Ten for a prayer cloth, a square cut from a bedsheet that had been pressed to the boy's belly overnight, to be sent through the mail to anybody who wrote. Whoever touched the light, Arlis said, the Lord would remember them, in their body and in their crops and in their herds.

By 1956 the healing tents were thicker on the roads than they had ever been. And the drought was in its seventh year. The tanks were dry and cracked into plates. Ranchers were burning the spines off the prickly pear at night with kerosene burners so the cattle could eat it, and you could see the little flames moving on the hills for miles, and the cattle following the flames. Men who had lost the place, or were about to, stood in line in the sawdust with a dollar in their hand and laid their palm flat on a fourteen-year-old boy's stomach, and some of them cried. Fentress's cigar box was full most nights. The boy stood still and let them. He had been doing it since he was nine. He thought it was what he was for.

III. Ransom

The camp-meeting ground · August 1956

In the middle of August they came to Ransom, the county seat, on the river, and pitched the tent on the old camp-meeting ground east of town, between the square and the cemetery, next to the tabernacle with the gray wooden moon in its gable. Nobody had held a meeting under the tabernacle since the war.

On the Saturday morning, early, the whole town came down the road past the tent, walking and in pickups, in their good clothes, with flowers in coffee cans and cakes under dish towels and casseroles wrapped in newspaper to keep them hot. Arlis stood at the front of the tent and asked them where they were going.

To Mr. Hext's, a woman said. *For Mrs. Tolliver.* Mrs. Tolliver had taught the third grade in Ransom for forty-one years and had died on Thursday, and she was laid out at Hext Furniture and Funeral, up the hill from the tabernacle, and the visitation was all day.

Come in here first, Arlis said. *There is a boy in this tent with a light in his body that God put there. Whoever touches it, the Lord will remember. You never saw anything like it.*

A rancher named Corley Wade, who had sold the last of his cows in July, laughed, not unkindly.

Preacher, Mr. Hext has laid out every soul in this county for forty-seven years. There isn't one thing your boy can show him he hasn't seen.

They argued in the road. Arlis said a light from God was a light from God. The Ransom people said they had nothing against the boy and nothing against the Lord, but they were going to Mr. Hext's. Neither side gave an inch, and the cakes were getting warm. At last Fentress said, *Well, then let's all of us go up the hill and see,* and Arlis took Delmer by the arm.

IV. The Charm

Hext Furniture and Funeral · August to October

Wiley Hext was seventy-four. He had come to Ransom in 1909 to sell furniture, and in those days the furniture man also sold the coffins, and somebody had to lay the dead out in them, so he had learned that too. He ran the only ambulance in the county, a black Cadillac combination car that was a hearse by day and turned into an ambulance when the phone rang at night, with a cot in the back and a red light he clamped to the roof. He was a Church of Christ man, and a widower, and he did not talk much. When they came up the hill he was in the front parlor in his shirtsleeves, combing Mrs. Tolliver's white hair with a pocket comb and laying each curl where she had worn it.

Arlis brought the boy in at the door, and the light went out.

It went out between one step and the next. In the dim parlor, among the sprays of gladiolas, the boy stood there in his white shirt, and there was nothing in it but a boy. Somebody said afterward that he looked like a crow in a coal scuttle. Arlis took him back out on the porch, and in the shade of the porch the light came up again in his shirt, round and pale, plain as ever. They brought him back in to Mr. Hext, and it went out. The third time, Delmer went in by himself.

He stood by the casket in the dark of his own shirt and looked at the old man with the comb.

You know some way to put it out, he said.

I know one, Mr. Hext said.

Show me.

Mr. Hext laid another curl.

I can't show it to anybody that doesn't work here.

Out in the yard, by the tent truck, the boy told his uncle. Delmer had thought it through on the porch. A man who could put out a light like that could put out any light, any preacher's in Texas, and a boy who could put his own light out and bring it back would be the biggest thing on the sawdust trail. *You go on to Brady and Coleman,* he said. *Leave me here. I'll learn it in a few weeks and catch up with you, and then nobody in Texas can*

touch us. Arlis prayed over it and let him. Fentress looked at the boy a long time and said nothing.

• • •

He slept on a cot in the back of the furniture store, between the bedroom suites and the stacked kitchen chairs. He swept. He washed the Cadillac. He rode in it at night with Mr. Hext on the ambulance calls, to car wrecks on the San Saba highway, to ranch houses forty miles out where somebody's heart had stopped in the kitchen, and on those roads he saw the pear burners going on the hills in the dark, the little blue-and-yellow flames and the cattle crowding after them.

And he learned to wash the dead. Mr. Hext did it the old way, with a basin and a cloth, and he named the parts of the body aloud as he washed them, in a low plain voice, the way a man counts posts.

Hair of the head. Hair of the body. Nails. Teeth. Skin.

Delmer asked him the first night what that was.

That's what you say first, Mr. Hext said, *before you can learn the other.* And he went on. *Flesh. Sinews. Bones. Marrow. Kidneys. Heart.* Then he made the boy say it, every part, every body, over and over, the old rancher from Katemcy and the baby from the Mexican side of town across the river and the drowned man they brought up out of the Llano at Kingsland, and when the boy had all of it by heart Mr. Hext gave him a chapter of the Bible to learn as well, from the back of a funeral card he kept in his shirt pocket, and had him say that over the washing too.

> *While the sun, or the light, or the moon, or the stars, be not darkened, nor the clouds return after the rain: In the day when the keepers of the house shall tremble, and the strong men shall bow themselves, and the grinders cease because they are few, and those that look out of the windows be darkened,*
>
> *— Ecclesiastes 12:2–3*

The boy said it all, and washed, and said it again. The keepers of the house were the hands, Mr. Hext told him, and the strong men were the

legs, and the grinders were the teeth, and the windows were the eyes. The boy looked at his own hands in the basin. In the evenings, after supper at the café, he sat on the loading dock behind the store with the light off in him and looked at the hills.

Arlis came back through Ransom at the end of September, with the tent folded on the truck, on his way to a meeting at Menard.

You learned it yet?

Not yet, Delmer said. *I'm learning it.*

V. The Bench

The courthouse square · November 1956

Arlis came again in November, and this time Fentress was driving. The drought had not broken, and the meetings had been thin all fall; people who had sold their cattle had no dollars left to put in a cigar box. They found the boy on the courthouse square in a pair of Mr. Hext's old khakis with the cuffs turned up, waiting with the Cadillac outside the drugstore while the old man got his prescription.

Well? Arlis said. *Have you got it?*

Delmer looked at his uncle, and at Fentress behind the wheel, and at the tent folded in the truck bed with the generator.

Y'all go on, he said. *I'm not coming. I'm not ever going back out there.*

Arlis argued with him and then prayed with him right there on the sidewalk, with his hand on the boy's head, and the boy let him. Then the truck went off down the San Saba road. Fentress lifted two fingers off the wheel as they passed the bench.

The old men on the bench under the pecan by the courthouse door had heard every word. They played dominoes there every morning there was no rain, which that year was every morning, and they knew the boy, the way they knew everybody who had come to town since 1910. When Mr. Hext came out of the drugstore one of them, Corley Wade's daddy, called out to him.

Wiley. Your boy just told his people he's done with the tent for good. Not ever, he said.

I heard him, Mr. Hext said.

Well, you know that's a lie. That's a fourteen-year-old boy. He'll be back in that tent by Christmas, first time he wants a dollar.

Mr. Hext put the little paper sack in his coat pocket and stood a minute on the curb, looking at the boy by the car. He did not argue with men on benches as a rule.

He's telling the truth, he said. *His eye is single.* And when they looked at him he said the rest of it, the way he said the parts of the body over a basin, plain, so they would have it right.

> *The light of the body is the eye: if therefore thine eye be single, thy whole body shall be full of light.*
>
> *— Matthew 6:22*

Then he got into the Cadillac, and the boy drove him home, because the old man's eyes were going at night by then.

• • •

He ran Hext Funeral Home for thirty-eight years after the old man died. He never preached and he never went back on the road. People in Ransom said he had the gentlest hands in the county, and that he could come into a house where somebody had just died and the whole house would go quiet, the way a dog does when you put your hand on it.

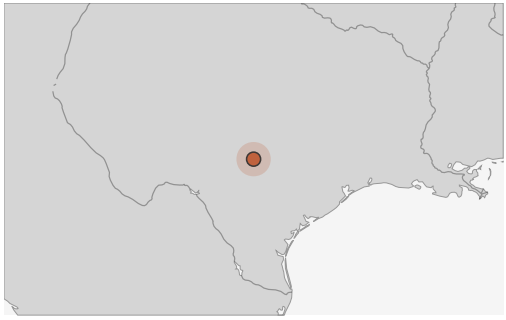
Nobody ever saw the light again. The cedar moon is still in the gable of the tabernacle on the camp-meeting ground, gone silver, and the nail heads around its edge have rusted into it. On clear nights, when the real moon comes up over the cemetery hill behind it, the two of them look about the same size, and about the same color, and for a minute you can't say which one is giving the light.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who is bright like the moon, pure, serene, undisturbed, and in whom all gaiety is extinct.*
>
> Dhammapada 413, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, a frontier forester shows a merchant a stand of red sandalwood, and when a shrine is raised over the relics of the earlier Buddha Kassapa he sets a moon-shaped disk of sandalwood inside it. Reborn in a rich Brahmin family at Rājagaha, he has a light like the moon shining from his navel and is named Candābha, "Moonlight." Brahmins carry him from town to town in a carriage and charge people a hundred or a thousand coins to stroke his body for luck. At Sāvatthī they quarrel with the Buddha's lay followers and bring the boy to the monastery to see whose power is greater, and in the Buddha's presence the light goes out three times; the boy, "like a crow in a basket of charcoal," asks for the charm that does it, is told it can only be taught to one who has gone forth, ordains, and is given the meditation on the thirty-two parts of the body as "a preliminary." He becomes an arahant within days and tells the Brahmins to go, since he will never return. The monks think he is lying; the Buddha says he speaks the truth. Read the full commentary story, and about the contemplation of the body's parts.



Llano River country, Texas

The Hill Country, *1956*

The 1950s Texas drought ran from about 1949 to 1957, and by its end 244 of the state's 254 counties had been declared federal drought disaster areas. Ranchers fed prickly pear to their cattle, burning off the spines with kerosene pear burners. In the hills west of Austin, cedar choppers, Scotch-Irish families who had come by way of Appalachia and the Ozarks, cut Ashe juniper for fence posts and burned it for char-

coal; their best years were the 1940s and 1950s, before chainsaws and steel posts put most of them out of work around 1960.

The postwar healing revival began in 1946 and peaked in 1956, when 49 evangelists were holding major campaigns. In small towns the undertaker often ran the only ambulance, in a combination car that served as hearse or ambulance as needed, a practice that lasted in the United States until the late 1970s. The drought broke in the spring of 1957, with rains that brought deadly floods.

After the story of the Elder Candābha from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 413). The original. Scripture from the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.31

Seven Winters

Now, methinks, I stand easy.
— John Bunyan, The Pilgrim's Progress, the Second Part

The old people gave it this way, on the south end of San Juan Island.

I. The Carrying

Howard County, Missouri, and Marysville, California · 1852–1858

LAVINIA TOLLIVER WAS CARRYING WHEN HER HUSBAND bought her. That was in Howard County, Missouri, in the spring of 1852. Amos Tolliver had been two years in the California diggings with the man who owned him. He came home with his own price paid and nine hundred dollars over in a belt, and he laid the nine hundred down for his wife. The paper was signed on a Tuesday. She was some four months along, and that night she told Amos the child had waited to have a free mother, and it could wait a little longer and have free ground.

People have told it since as though she were boasting. She said afterward that she only knew it, the way you know rain is coming.

They went out from Independence with a train in May. It was the cholera year on the Platte, with graves at every camp, and she walked most of the way behind the wagon because the jolting was worse than walking. Her time came due on the Humboldt and went by. The child moved in her, strong, and stayed where it was.

They stopped at Marysville. Amos shod mules and Viney washed for miners. California was called free soil. That same spring its legislature had made a law under which a colored person brought in before statehood could be claimed and carried back, and under an older one no colored person could give evidence against a white man in any court, so

that Amos could be robbed at noon in the street and have no witness. It was not the ground she had meant.

She carried a year past her time, and then two. A doctor examined her, said there was a living child and that he could not account for it, and charged five dollars. The women at church stopped asking. She was not sick. She was heavy and slept propped against the wall, and she worked every day. In the evenings Amos read to her from the one book besides the Bible that had come across the plains with them, a *Pilgrim's Progress* with the boards gone. Near the beginning the pilgrim falls in a bog on the road, and someone asks why the place is never fixed. She had Amos read the answer twice each time he came to it. *This miry slough is such a place as cannot be mended.*

That's so, she would say. *It isn't there for mending. It's there to get over.*

They were six winters in California. In the spring of 1858 a bill went through the Assembly to shut the state against any more colored people, and a young man named Archy Lee was tried over and over in the courts on the question of whether he belonged to himself. In April the colored people of San Francisco sent thirty-five of their number north on the steamer *Commodore* to the English colony at Victoria, whose governor had sent word that they would be received there like anyone. Hundreds followed. The Tollivers went in July.

II. Seven Days

San Juan Island · October 1859

VICTORIA THAT YEAR WAS TENTS AND MUD AND MEN GOING TO the Fraser for gold. Viney carried through a seventh winter there. Seven miles over the strait lay an island that the Queen and the United States both claimed, with little on it but the Hudson's Bay Company's sheep. In the spring of 1859 Amos hired on with the Company farm there. He was given a cabin with half a roof at a sheep station above the bay, among Kanaka shepherds from the Sandwich Islands and their wives. The Lummi and Songhees people had fished the reefs off that shore longer than anybody could say. Neither country had asked them.

In June an American settler shot a Company pig in his potatoes. By August there were American soldiers dug in on the south end with cannon, and five British warships lay in the bay with their ports open. Amos went for his wife in October all the same, because she sent for him to.

A Company sloop put them off at low water, and she went over the side and waded up onto the stones. She stood there a minute with her skirt dripping. She looked at the flag on the hill and then at the flags on the ships.

Neither one has got it yet, she said.

This will do, she said, and the first pain took her before the boxes were ashore.

It went on seven days. The child lay crosswise. Mrs. Oakes, whose husband kept the Company's oxen, came up from the home farm and did not go back. Keoni's wife, a Songhees woman from the next cabin, stayed two nights; twice she turned the child with her hands from outside, and twice it turned back. The roof was half on, and it rained.

Mrs. Oakes told it for forty years. She said that Viney did not curse or beg, and that when the pains were at their height she said three things over, always the same three. *There is One who went through worse than this to make an end of it. There are people walking after Him, and I am one. There is a country where this is not.* Then she would get her breath and wait for the next.

On the sixth morning she called Amos to the bed.

Go over to Victoria, to Mr. Pembroke. Don't ask him for a thing. Tell him Viney Tolliver greets him.

III. The Chair

Yates Street, Victoria · the seventh day

Lot Pembroke kept a barber's chair on Yates Street. He had been a ship's cook for thirty years, out of Newport first and then New Bedford, and a Quaker woman had taught him his letters when he was a boy. He owned a razor case, a Bible and a Bunyan. He read from the Bunyan to whoever was under the lather, and on Thursday nights he led a

CLASS OF COLORED PEOPLE IN THE ROOM BEHIND THE SHOP. The Tollivers had sat in that class for a year. He seldom said ten words together that were his own.

It should have been one day by canoe. Keoni and his brother paddled, and fog held them overnight on a rock in the middle of the strait. Amos came into the shop at noon on the seventh day, wet to the knees. Mr. Pembroke was shaving the mate of a lumber brig.

Viney Tolliver greets you, Amos said. He had meant to stop there, as he had been told. *Seven days she's been at it,* he said.

Mr. Pembroke lifted the razor off the mate's throat and held it in the air. He looked at the clock on his wall, which said a quarter past twelve.

Let Lavinia Tolliver be well, he said. *Let her be well, and bring a well son.*

Then he finished the mate's left cheek. He told Amos to eat something and go home.

Amos was back the next evening. Mrs. Oakes met him on the stones with her sleeves still rolled. It was a boy. He had come on the seventh day a little after noon, as near as she could judge it by the tide. He had turned of himself, she said, like a man rolling over in bed, and after that it was no more trouble than any.

IV. The Dipper

The sheep station · November 1859

VINEY WAS ON HER FEET IN THREE DAYS. SHE SENT WORD BY the Company sloop that Mr. Pembroke and the whole class were to come up, and she would feed them a week.

Fourteen came. They slept on fir boughs in the cabin and under the sloop's sail, and for seven days she fed them mutton, clams, potatoes, bread out of the Dutch oven, and salmon bought off the canoes at a bit apiece. That same week the general the President had sent came to terms with the governor, and most of the soldiers and all but one of the ships went away.

Everybody who was there told the next part the same way. The child was three weeks old, and he looked three weeks old. On the first day of

the feast he got down off the bed. He took the tin dipper from its nail, went to the bucket, and strained creek water through a cloth to get the fir needles out. Then he carried it round to the company in both hands, beginning with Mr. Pembroke. He did that all seven days and never spoke. Mr. Pembroke took the dipper from him each time and said thank you, as he would to a grown man, and made no other remark. When the sloop had gone the child lay down again and was a baby for the usual time.

Mrs. Oakes said he had had seven years to get his legs under him.

They named him Josiah. All his life he was called Tarry.

V. Halfway In

Griffin Bay · August 1880

THE TWO COUNTRIES KEPT A CAMP APIECE ON THE ISLAND FOR twelve years and never fired a shot. In 1872 the Emperor of Germany, who had been asked to judge, gave the island to the United States. The marines went home, and most of the Kanaka families crossed to the British side, where they could hold land. The Tollivers stayed. There had been a war by then, and the ground was not what it had been in 1852. Tarry was twenty. He had signed his share of the homestead over to his sisters and he owned a boat. He carried people and freight across the line to Victoria and back for what they could pay, and Sundays he spoke a little at the schoolhouse. Nobody on the south end had seen him hurried, or put out, or wanting anything that was not already in his hand.

Mr. Pembroke was past eighty. He came up that August for the last time, to a meeting on the prairie above the bay, and after the dinner the old hands sat in the lee of the wagons and got to talking about Tarry, who was down at the water.

Think of it, Mrs. Oakes said. *Seven years shut up in the dark. Over the Platte in the cholera, and six years in California, and then seven days crosswise in the rain with the guns run out. What that boy came through before he drew a breath.*

They all agreed it was a wonder he was right in his mind.

Mr. Pembroke had seemed to be asleep. *He came through it,* he said. *He is not in any of it now.*

The Bunyan was in his coat. He turned to the end of the second part, where the last of the pilgrims goes down into the river, stops when he is halfway over, and talks to his friends on the bank. He read it in the voice he had used over the lather.

> *This river has been a terror to many; yea, the thoughts of it also have often frightened me. Now, methinks, I stand easy, my foot is fixed upon that upon which the feet of the priests that bare the ark of the covenant stood, while Israel went over this Jordan. The waters, indeed, are to the palate bitter, and to the stomach cold; yet the thoughts of what I am going to, and of the conduct that waits for me on the other side, doth lie as a glowing coal at my heart. I see myself now at the end of my journey, my toilsome days are ended.*
>
> *— John Bunyan, The Pilgrim's Progress, the Second Part*

Most of us will be old before we can say that, Mr. Pembroke said. *That one says it at twenty, on a week day.*

Toward evening Tarry took him down to the boat. The tide was out and she lay off the stones in three feet of water. Tarry walked out into the bay to his thighs and held the gunwale steady while two men handed the old barber across. That water is cold in August. He stood in it with both hands on the boat, in no hurry at all, until Mr. Pembroke was seated and had found his hat.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has traversed this miry road, the impassable world and its vanity, who has gone through, and reached the other shore, is thoughtful, guileless, free from doubts, free from attachment, and content.*
>
> Dhammapada 414, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Suppavāsā of the Koliya clan carries a child for seven years and then labors for seven days because the child lies awry. She bears the pain by holding three thoughts, of the Buddha, of his followers, and of the peace where such pain is not, and she sends her husband to greet the Buddha in her name. He says, "May Suppavāsā be healthy; in health and happiness may she bring forth a healthy son," and at that moment she does. She feeds the Buddha and his monks for seven days, and from the day of his birth the child strains their drinking water. He grows up to become a monk and a saint. When the monks marvel at how much he suffered in the womb, the Buddha says he is free of all of it now, and speaks the verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Sīvali.

San Juan Island, Washington

From California to San Juan Island, 1858–1859

California entered the Union as a free state, but an 1852 law let people who had been brought there enslaved before statehood be seized and returned, and Black Californians could not testify against whites in court. In 1858, the year of the Archy Lee case, the legislature took up a bill to bar Black immigration altogether. That April the Black community of San Francisco sent a Pioneer Committee of thirty-five north on the steamer *Commodore* to Victoria, in the British Colony of Vancouver Island, where Governor James Douglas, himself of mixed Caribbean ancestry, had let it be known they would be welcome. They landed on April 25, and several hundred people followed that year, among them Mifflin Gibbs. The Legislative Assembly of British Columbia tells the story here.

San Juan Island lies seven miles across Haro Strait from Victoria, in waters fished by Coast Salish peoples. The treaty of 1846 left it unclear which country owned it. In December 1853 the Hudson's Bay Company landed sheep and a crew of European, Hawaiian and Native men there and founded Belle Vue Sheep Farm; by 1859 some 4,500 sheep grazed at stations across the island. On June 15, 1859, an American settler shot a Company pig, and by August 461 American soldiers with fourteen cannon faced five British warships in what is called the Pig War. No one was hurt. General

Winfield Scott arrived in October and arranged a joint military occupation, which lasted until an arbitration under the German emperor awarded the islands to the United States in 1872. Both camps are now San Juan Island National Historical Park. The Tollivers, Keoni, Mrs. Oakes and Lot Pembroke are invented, and no Black family is recorded on the Company farm. *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678; second part 1684) was among the most widely owned books in English-speaking Protestant homes of the time; the text here follows George Offor's edition of the 1850s.

After the story of the Elder Sīvali from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 414). The original. Scripture from John Bunyan, The Pilgrim's Progress (1678, 1684). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.32

Honeyed Grass

> *...as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul.*
> *— 1 Peter 2:11*

Also ist mir's gesagt worden, on the Cocalico.

I. The Outer Ring

Germantown and the Ridge, Pennsylvania · summer 1744

Heinrich Schönsee tanned leather on the Wingohocking and owned shares in three ships, and it was said in Germantown that he could have bought the Main Street from the market square to Chestnut Hill and had money over. He had one child, a son, Matthias, who was nineteen and could sing. The tanyard and the ships were to be his.

One First-day after dinner Matthias saw people going out along the road toward the Ridge, a good many of them, with loaves under their arms and candles in their hands. He asked where they were going.

To hear the old man, they said.

I will go too.

The old man was called Vater Lorenz. He had come over fifty years before with the forty brethren who built their cabins in the woods above the Wissahickon to wait for the Lord, who was to come that same year. The Lord had not come that year. The master of the forty had died young, and the rest had married or wandered off, and the cabins had fallen in. Lorenz had stayed. He had a hut and a spring and a patch of beans. On First-days he sat on a stump before the door and talked a little, and whoever had walked out sat on the ground. A boy named Christel, from the paper mill down the creek, carried his water.

Matthias sat at the back, in the outer ring. The old man looked at him once. Then he spoke as he always did, of plain things in their order: of giving, of keeping one's word, of what the body is, of how one wanting hauls the next one in behind it like a barge horse. Matthias listened and thought, *I cannot do this in my father's house. Nine dishes on the table and a clerk at my elbow. A life scoured as clean as a shell is not lived between a tanyard and a counting room.*

When the people got up to go, he stayed, and asked to be taken in.

Have your father and mother said yes?

No.

Then go home. I take no man's son from him.

They said no all summer. In August he stopped eating. He lay on the floor of his room, and on the seventh day his mother came up with broth and he turned his face from it, and she went down and told her husband that a son in the woods was better than a son under the churchyard. So they gave him leave. He went up the Ridge with nothing in his hands. The old man cut his hair and gave him a gray coat.

He stayed a year. Every week his mother sent a girl out the road with a covered basket, and every week he sent it back as it came. At the end of the year he thought, *What is the use of my living here, two miles from her kitchen?* He had heard of the Camp of the Solitary on the Cocalico, sixty miles west, where the brethren slept on boards and ate once a day and sang. He asked leave. The old man said, *Go,* and he walked there.

II. The Fair

Germantown · November 1746

The November fair came on in Philadelphia, and the young men of Germantown rode down to it past the Schönsee house. The mother stood at the window. There went the Kepler boy, who had learned his letters on the same bench as Matthias, in a blue coat with silver buttons. There went young Dietz in a chaise with a wife beside him and a drummer walking ahead. She sat down on the window seat and wept, and her husband came and stood by her and wept as well.

That is past our son's getting now, she said.

A woman came to the house that same hour with lace to sell. She was Anna Barbara Kuntz, called Bärbel, twenty-four years old. She had come over from the Palatinate at fourteen and been sold off the ship for her passage, seven years to a tavern on Water Street. When the seven years were out she had nothing but what she had learned there, and she had taken rooms in the part of the city they called Helltown, where a clever woman who was good company could keep herself. She saw the mother's face.

Mother, why do you weep?

I keep thinking of my son.

Where is he?

Gone among the brethren.

Would it not be right to bring him home?

It would. He does not wish it. He has left the Ridge now and gone out to the Cocalico.

Bärbel set down her lace.

Suppose I brought him home. What would you do for me?

The mother looked at her a long while, and knew what she was, and said it anyway.

You would be the wife of this house and carry its keys. All of it would be yours after us.

Then give me my expenses.

She took the money and hired a wagon, a maid and a boy to walk ahead of her, and went west on the Lancaster road like a merchant's widow.

III. The Tenor

Ephrata · winter 1747

On the Cocalico they had named him Brother Simeon. He wore the white habit with the hood and went barefoot until the ground froze. He slept on a bench the width of his shoulders with a block of wood under his head, and rose at midnight, and ate one meal a day.

None of it was hard for him. The hard thing, and the thing he loved, was the singing school.

The Superintendent had made a music of his own for them, in four parts and five and six, the women above and the brothers below, and he kept the school himself, four hours at a stretch, ending at midnight. They sang with the mouth hardly open and the breath held back, so that the sound came from nowhere a visitor could point to. People of quality drove out from Lancaster to hear it and went home quiet. Matthias had the high part among the brothers. It was the one true note he owned, and it sat at the very top of what he could reach. The Brethren wrote the rule of that school down afterward in their chronicle.

> *…he declared all fruit, milk, meat, to be viands injurious to the voice.*
>
> *…godly virtue must be at the source of our whole walk, because by it you obtain favor with the spirit of singing, which is the Holy Spirit.*
>
> *— Chronicon Ephratense, ch. XXIV*

The love of women stood in that list too. The Superintendent had struck it out, thinking some would take offence, and the Brethren had made him put it back.

Every Sixth-day they sent Brother Simeon the thirteen miles to Lancaster for rags. The paper mill ate rags, and the press ate paper, and that year the press was printing the book of their hymns. He went up one side of each street and down the other with a sack, and knocked at every door and passed none by, the brick houses and the log ones alike. And he had bound himself by a rule of his own, harder than the house asked. At a door he would take rags and a cup of cold water and nothing else. He would eat nothing on the road but the bread in his sleeve.

IV. Queen Street

Lancaster · April to July 1747

Bärbel took note of the street he came in by. She hired the tallest house on it, two floors of brick and two garrets one above the

other under a steep German roof with a knob at the peak. She baked on Fifth-day night so that the house smelled of it on Sixth-day morning.

The first weeks she gave him rags, good ones, a torn linen sheet, and cold water in a cup, and stood back from the door with her eyes down. He blessed the house and went on.

Then there was a small loaf in the sack among the rags, still warm. He found it on the road home. Bread was what he ate; it would have been waste to throw it in the ditch. It was white bread, and there was butter worked into it. The next week there was another.

In May she said, *Brother, sit down right here on the bench and eat it while it is hot.* She put out her hands for his sack, and he gave it to her. She brought milk in a cup. *There is no better door on your whole road than this one,* she said, and it was so. He sat on her bench in the sun every Sixth-day of that month.

There were boys on Queen Street. She gave them honey cakes and told them, *When the brother comes, you come too, and run up and down before the bench and kick up the dust. If I tell you to stop, pay me no mind.* They came and kicked up the dust. She called to them to stop. They paid her no mind. The next week she said, *Brother, these boys. I cannot do anything with them. Sit inside.*

Inside there was a table with a cloth, and soup with meat in it, and pears stewed in honey. He ate what was set before him.

She gave the boys more cakes, and two kettle lids, and a toy drum. *When he is at the table, make a noise under the window. If I tell you to stop, pay me no mind.* They did it gladly. The next week she said, *Brother, there is no bearing it down here. Sit upstairs.*

All this time the note was leaving him. First it came late. Then it came thick, like a thing sung through a blanket. Twice in June the midnight school was stopped on his account, and forty faces in white hoods turned and waited while he looked for it and could not find it. He knew why. And on the next Sixth-day morning he had his hand up to knock on her door before he had so much as thought about it.

He went up the stairs ahead of her. She shut each door behind them as they climbed, the door at the stair foot and the door to the first garret and the door to the second, and at the top of the house, under the peak, there was a chair, and he sat down in it.

V. The Top of the House

Lancaster and the Ridge · a Sixth-day in July

THEY SAY THERE ARE FORTY WAYS, AND THAT SHE KNEW THEM. She yawned and stretched. She bent to the floor for something that had not fallen. She looked ashamed and rubbed one bare foot upon the other. She scratched on the boards with a stick. She spoke loud, as though the street could hear, and then low, as though no one must. She ate a pear and held it out to him. She sang a little, and wept a little, and laughed at herself for weeping. She took off her cap and put it on again. She loosened what was laced and laced it. Then she stood in front of him with her hair down and said it to him as a rhyme, the way a girl says a counting game.

My feet are washed, my shoes are red. You are young, and you are mine. I am young, and I am yours. We will both turn holy when we are old and go to God on two sticks.

Brother Simeon sat with his hands on his knees. *What have I done,* he thought. *I never looked where I was walking.* He was shaken through. And he did not get up.

• • •

At that same hour, sixty miles east, Vater Lorenz was sitting on his stump on the Ridge with his dinner of bread on his knee, and he smiled. Christel had never seen him do it over nothing.

Father, what are you smiling at?

In Lancaster town, at the top of a house on Queen Street, there is a battle on between Matthias Schönsee and a woman from Philadelphia.

Who is going to win, and who is going to lose?

Matthias is going to win. The woman is going to lose.

He went on sitting where he was, with the bread on his knee. And in the top garret on Queen Street he was standing between the chair and the woman, in his gray coat with the bean dirt on it, and there was more light in that garret than the one small window gave. Bärbel did not see him. She saw the brother look past her shoulder, and she felt the hair rise on her arms, and she stepped back.

Matthias, the old man said. *Both. The thing wanted, and the wanting. Let them both go and look for nothing.* And he said the verse to him in Luther's words, as it stood in the new Bible Christoph Saur had printed in Germantown: *als die Fremdlinge und Pilgrime, enthaltet euch von fleischlichen Lüsten, welche wider die Seele streiten.*

> *Dearly beloved, I beseech you as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul.*
>
> *— 1 Peter 2:11*

Brother Simeon heard it to the end. When it ended, there was nothing left in him that leaned toward her or toward her table, or toward anything else.

Then he rose out of the chair, and kept on rising. He went up through the peak of the roof beside the knob, and not one shingle was started. The three boys were under the window with their kettle lids. They saw something white go up off the top of the tall house the way a goose goes up off a pond, and turn east. They told it all their lives.

Bärbel sat down on the top stair. After a while she put up her hair and went down and opened the three doors, and paid the boys what she owed them.

VI. Honey

The Ridge · that evening, and the First-day after

Before the old man had finished his bread, Matthias was kneeling in the bean patch in front of him in the white habit, with his hood back. He looked at the old man from his cap to his cracked

SHOES, THE WHOLE BODY OF HIM, THE WAY A MAN LOOKS AT the house he was born in. Then he put his forehead to the ground. Christel dropped the water bucket and had to go back down for more.

On First-day the people who walked out had the story already, from a carter. They sat on the ground and talked it over among themselves. *For the sake of his tongue,* they said. *Bread with butter in it. He was that near lost, and the old man held him up.*

Vater Lorenz heard them.

It is not the first time I have seen that one caught by the tongue, he said. *Nor the first time I spoke for him.* And he told them a thing from before he crossed the water, when he was a page of fourteen at the court of a small count on the Lahn.

The count had a pleasure garden and a gardener named Sander. A roe deer began coming into the garden, a wild one out of the hill forest, the kind that is gone at the sight of a man. Sander let it go and did not frighten it. One day the count asked him, *Have you seen anything strange in the garden? Only a roe that comes, sir. Could you catch it? With a little honey I could bring it right into your hall.*

So he was given honey. He smeared it on the grass where the roe fed, and hid. The roe tasted the honeyed grass and after that would feed nowhere else. Then Sander let himself be seen, a little, at a distance. The first days it ran. Then it stood. Before long it was eating grass out of his hand.

Then he strewed the path from the garden to the house with cut boughs, thick as a carpet, so that it looked like more forest. He hung a crock of honey from his shoulder and stuck a bunch of grass in his belt, and he walked ahead dropping honeyed wisps, one and then one, and the roe came after him with its head down, over the sill and into the hall. They shut the doors.

When it saw the people, it ran from wall to wall and shook. The count came down from his chamber and looked at it. *This creature,* he said, *will not go back for a week to a place where it has so much as seen a man. Where it has once been frightened it will not go again in all its life. And look where its tongue has brought it.*

I was standing by the door with the candle, the old man said. *I said, My lord, there is nothing worse than taste. Not at home, and not among friends. It gave this one to Sander. He laughed, since I was fourteen. Then he had them open the doors.*

And the roe? said Christel.

It went out between the boughs. There was honeyed grass lying the whole length of that path. It did not put its head down once.

• • •

Brother Simeon walked back to the Cocalico that week on his feet, like anybody, and it took him three days. He carried the rag sack to Lancaster every Sixth-day as before and passed no door, and at the tall house on Queen Street, for as long as she had the lease of it, Bärbel gave him rags and he blessed the house. She stayed on in Lancaster afterward and baked for the town.

At the midnight school he stood in his place among the brothers with his mouth hardly open, as he had been taught, and the note was there.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who in this world, leaving all desires, travels about without a home, and in whom all concupiscence is extinct.*
>
> Dhammapada 415, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, Sundarasamudda ("Ocean of Beauty") is the son of a very rich house in Sāvatthī who wins his parents' leave to become a monk and goes off to Rājagaha. His mother, weeping on a festival day, promises a courtesan the whole household if she can bring him back. The woman takes a house on his alms street and feeds him, first at the door, then on the veranda, then (with the help of some bribed boys) indoors, then on the top floor of a seven-storied mansion, where she tries every art on him. The Buddha, far away, smiles, tells Ānanda who will win, and sends a radiant image of himself with the verse; the monk becomes an arahant and leaves through the roof peak. The Buddha then tells how the same monk was once a wind-deer lured into a palace by honeyed grass. Read the full commentary story.

Ephrata, Pennsylvania

Ephrata and the Wissahickon, 1747

The Ephrata Cloister was founded in 1732 on Cocalico Creek in Lancaster County by Conrad Beissel, who appears here only as "the Superintendent." Its celibate brothers and sisters wore white habits, slept on narrow benches with wooden blocks for pillows, kept a midnight watch, ate one sparing meal a day, ran a paper mill and a press, and sang hymns in four and more parts to Beissel's own system of harmony. The community's chronicle, the *Chronicon Ephratense* (1786; quoted from J. Max Hark's 1889 translation), records that before opening the singing school Beissel judged fruit, milk and meat injurious to the voice, and that the Brethren insisted he keep a sentence saying the same of the love of women. The hymnal that carried that preface was printed at Ephrata in 1747. Brother Simeon, his rag round and his private rule are invented.

Vater Lorenz is invented too, but hermits like him were real. In 1694 about forty German Pietists under Johannes Kelpius settled on the ridge above Wissahickon Creek near Germantown to await the millennium; after Kelpius died, a few stayed on as solitaries into the 1740s and were visited for counsel. Christoph Saur printed Luther's Bible at Germantown in 1743, the first Bible in a European language printed in America. Many German immigrants of those years came as redemptioners, sold into terms of service to pay their passage.

After the story of the Elder Sundarasamudda from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 415). The original. Scripture from Luther's German Bible and the King James Version; the rule of the singing school from the *Chronicon Ephratense*, tr. J. Max Hark (1889). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.33

The Dog's Book

Strong and content I travel the open road.
— Walt Whitman, Song of the Open Road

The way it's written in the registers, on the Swift River.

I. The Cooler

South Fork of the Shenandoah, Virginia · July 1979

THERE WAS A HOTEL UPRIVER, SEVEN STORIES, AND THE MAN who owned it kept his daughter on the top floor with one maid to watch her. That was the summer people had started jumping off ridges under nylon kites. One evening a man came in at her window. The maid said afterward that he had no kite. He flew, she said, the way you would walk across a room.

In July the daughter had a boy. She sent the maid out for a new Coleman cooler, the green steel kind. She laid the baby in it on a folded towel, propped the lid with a wooden spoon, and put daisies and black-eyed Susans on top. *Carry this down and set it in the river,* she said. *If anybody asks, it's a picnic I'm sending to the church.*

The maid did as she was told. Nobody asked.

Six miles down, below a low-water bridge, two women were bathing. One was Opal Shifflett, who was sixty. The other was Dreama Good, who was not much younger. They saw a new cooler coming down the current with flowers on it.

That cooler's mine! Dreama called.

Then whatever's in it is mine, said Opal.

They waded out and brought it in to the gravel and lifted the lid. For a minute neither of them said a word. Then they both spoke at once, and

they kept at it for six weeks. Dreama held that a cooler and what it held were one article. Opal held that she had spoken plainly. The magistrate would not touch it. It went up to old Judge Rudacille at the courthouse, who heard them both out with his glasses pushed up on his forehead.

Mrs. Good, you called the cooler, and you take the cooler, he said. *Miss Shifflett, you take the child.*

Dreama used that cooler for thirty years and said it was the best she ever owned.

When Opal first washed the boy, his hair came up out of the basin in mats that no comb would go through. She named him Matthew and called him Matt.

Opal lived at a gap where the Appalachian Trail came down out of the park and crossed the road. She had fed hikers on her porch since there were hikers. There was one she fed every June, a lean schoolteacher with a gray beard who answered any short question at such length that the trail had named him Footnote. He had gone north every year since 1970, and he walked behind a dog.

She was a yellow dog of middle size with no collar. On her chest she had a white mark two inches wide and six inches long, the size and shape of the paint blazes on the trees. She belonged to nobody. Every town on the trail had tried to keep her at one time or another and had found her gone in the morning, and so she was called Gone. She walked north from Georgia each spring. People fell in behind her and found that they wanted less by the week. Those were Gone's people, and Opal thought more of them than she did of most churches.

I'm raising this one for the trail, she told Footnote. *When he can walk it, you take him.*

Two summers later the boy could walk, and Opal's heart was bad and she knew it. *Take him now,* she said.

Footnote squatted down and looked at the child for some time. Gone came up and smelled the boy's hands. She did not lie down by him.

Not yet, Opal, Footnote said. *He's got a house in him. He's got a whole hill in him, and he'll have to have it before he can leave it. But I know a man in Maine.*

So the boy went north. It is in the registers that he rode most of Pennsylvania on top of Footnote's pack.

II. The Store

Starbird Falls, Maine · 1981 *to* 2001

STARBIRD FALLS IS ELEVEN MILES DOWN THE ROAD FROM where the trail crosses, in Oxford County, on the Swift River. People there have panned gold out of the Swift for a hundred and fifty years, a few flakes to the pan, and have always wondered where it washed down from.

Orrin Thurlow kept the store by the bridge. He let hikers sleep in his barn and held their mail, and he had known Footnote for ten years. *He'll walk, later on,* Footnote told him. *Right now he's two. Keep him a while.* Orrin was a widower with a daughter, Lila, who lived winters with his sister in Rumford. He gave the boy the room over the store and brought him up as his own.

Orrin was a good man and a poor storekeeper. He bought whatever a salesman showed him and sold perhaps half. He had taken over the place in 1986, and by the end of 1997 he had twelve years of goods on the shelves, in the back room and in the cellar. There were lamp chimneys and wicks. There were kerosene cans, stovepipe elbows, candles by the gross, rock salt and wool socks. He had flashlight batteries in sizes nobody used. He had a carton of cumin that no one in Oxford County had ever asked for.

On the seventh of January, 1998, a Wednesday, Orrin had to go down to Rumford. He sat Matt on the stool behind the register and went through the stock with him. *This is worth so much and that is worth so much. If you can get it, sell it.* Matt was eighteen. He wrote it all down.

The freezing rain started that night. By Thursday every wire in the county was on the ground under two inches of ice. The power was out from the mountains to the coast, and it stayed out for two weeks in some places. Nobody could get to Rumford or to anywhere else.

Whatever it is that looks after towns sent every soul in that valley to Thurlow's. They came on foot with sleds. They wanted wicks and chimneys, kerosene, stovepipe, candles, salt, socks, and batteries in every size. A woman cooking for eleven on a camp stove bought the pepper. A man from away, iced in at his camp, bought the cumin. Matt sold by flashlight from first light until after dark, at Orrin's prices to the cent, and wrote down every sale.

Orrin got home Friday behind a plow. He stood in the door and looked at the bare shelves.

Matt, he said, *have you lost me my whole stock?*

I haven't lost anything. Here's for the wicks. Here's for the stovepipe. Here's for the cumin. It was all in a cigar box, with the list.

Orrin counted it twice. *Here's one who could make a living on a bare ledge,* he said, and he said it around town until people were tired of it.

Lila came home that spring for good. She and Matt were married in June of 2000, and Orrin had a house built for them on the rise behind the store. It was done in September of 2001. Matt carried the last box up himself.

He set one foot on the threshold, and the ground behind the house opened. A hill of gold came up out of it, a hundred and twenty feet high. It stood above the spruce. It was the same pale gold as the flakes in the Swift, and on a clear afternoon you could see it from the fire tower.

The state sent a geologist, who measured it and went home. Then a man came up from the bank in Portland in a dark suit, carrying papers and a large green umbrella with the bank's name on it. He left the umbrella. That was how the town knew for certain. After that he was Mr. Shifflett at the bank, and at the store he was still Matt.

III. The Brick, the Whip and the Cord

Starbird Falls and points west · 2024

They had three boys, Wade, Curtis and Ben. Matt ran the store after Orrin. He paid for the school roof, the new plow truck and three parts in four of the town budget. He took what he needed from the

HILL WITH A SPADE AND DID NOT THINK ABOUT IT MUCH. Every September Gone came down the road with her people. He fed them in the yard and stood a while afterward watching them go back up toward the crossing.

Lila died in the winter of 2021. By the next fall the boys were men, or near it, and he knew what he wanted. But he had got it into his head that a man could not walk off from the biggest pile there was. The biggest pile had duties. If there were another like it somewhere, the town would let him go.

So he made a brick, a buggy whip and a length of cord, all three of gold. He gave them to Dunc Coolidge and Leroy Poulin, who clerked for him. *Drive around the country,* he said. *Act like you're after nothing in particular. See if anybody has what we have.*

They drove a long way. In the Texas Panhandle a rancher named Ramsey found them leaning on his fence.

What are you boys after?

Nothing in particular, said Dunc.

Ramsey looked at the whip. *Nobody carries a gold buggy whip after nothing in particular. Go on around back and take a look.*

Behind the house were eight acres of fenced caliche. In it were rams made of gold, as big as horses, going at each other back to back and tearing up the ground. Dunc and Leroy walked around among them for a while. Then they came out.

Find what you were after? said Ramsey.

Yes sir.

Then go home.

They told it to Matt in the store. *What have you got?* Leroy said. *This Ramsey has that much in livestock.*

Matt was more pleased than they had seen him since Lila. *That's one,* he said. *See if there's another.* This time he gave them a blanket of vicuña wool, with a paper saying it was worth a hundred thousand dollars.

They took it to Lake Tahoe, to the public beach under the wall of a man named Bright. They piled up driftwood and lit it.

What are you doing? said a man at the gate.

We've got a blanket here worth a hundred thousand dollars, said Dunc. *We can't find a buyer, and we're afraid to carry it for fear of robbers. So we'll burn it and go home.*

Bright heard and sent for them. He counted out a hundred thousand dollars and gave the blanket straight back. *Take that to the woman who sweeps the gatehouse.*

The woman who swept the gatehouse felt of it and began to cry. She went to Bright. *If I've done wrong, tell me what. Why would you send me a scratchy thing like this? I can't wear it and I can't sleep under it.*

It isn't for that, Bright said. *Roll it up at the foot of your bed. It's to dry your feet on when you've had your bath. Can you use it for that?*

I can do that, she said, and took it away.

They heard other things there. There was not a lamp in that house, and the family ate and read by the light of stones. The cook had one pot of rice, which she had never yet got to the bottom of. They did not stay to see.

What have you got, Matt? said Dunc, when they were home.

Not much, it sounds like, said Matt. *Good. Now they'll let me go.*

IV. Article 31

Town meeting, the Grange hall · March 2025

Town meeting is the first Saturday in March. The warrant that year had thirty-three articles. They voted the plow contract and the salt shed and argued forty minutes over a culvert. Then Mrs. Arsenault, the moderator, read the next one in the same voice.

Article 31. To see if the Town will give Matthew Shifflett leave to go.

It was quiet enough to hear the furnace.

Go where? said the first selectman.

Up the trail, Matt said. He stood, with his cap in his hands. *Behind the dog. For good.*

And who pays for the school?

The hill stays where it is. My boys stay with it. I can't carry it and I'm not asking to. He told them about Ramsey's eight acres and about the woman

at the gatehouse drying her feet. *I thought we had the only one. There's more of it around than I knew. I thought you ought to hear that before you voted.*

An old man in the back said he had known Matt since he came up the road on a hiker's pack, and he had always figured somebody would come back for him. A woman said her mother had bought the pepper.

They voted by show of hands. Mrs. Arsenault did not need to count.

The ayes have it, she said. *Go where you're inclined, Matt. Article 32.*

V. The Spade

Behind the house · the next morning

He took the three of them up behind the house after breakfast. He had a spade with him that he had made years before from the hill itself.

Wade. Cut me a piece out of it.

Wade was twenty-three and strong. He set his boot on the spade and drove it. It rang as if he had hit ledge, and the shock went up both his arms. There was no mark on the hill.

Matt took the spade and gave it to Curtis. Curtis picked a different place and swung with his whole back. It rang the same.

Then he gave it to Ben, who was nineteen. Ben pushed it in with one foot. It went in to the step, as it would go into a potato hill in June, and he turned up a spadeful of gold as loose as loam.

That'll do, Ben.

Wade and Curtis stood looking at the place.

This didn't come up for you two, Matt said. He said it gently. *It came up for me and for Ben. You'll have to go shares with him. He'll do right by you.*

Wade started to ask why, and then he remembered why. Curtis had remembered already.

VI. The North Wall

Starbird Falls · September 2014

Footnote had died in 2012, on the trail, in his sleep, at eighty-one. Two years later Gone's people were building a lean-to in his name on the brook above the crossing. They had the floor laid, the roof on and three walls up. Then the money ran out, and the north side stood open to the weather.

One of them was a carpenter called Plumb. He came down to Starbird Falls to go door to door. *The north wall's open on Footnote's lean-to,* he told people. *We're short for the logs.* People gave him what they had. Then he climbed the rise to the house in front of the hill, reasoning as anybody would have.

Matt and Lila were in the middle of a fight. It was about nothing, the kind you have in a house with too much in it. Matt came to the door with his face still hot.

The north wall's open on the lean-to, Plumb said. *I figured you of all people would want to know.*

Go throw your dog in the river, Matt said.

Plumb stood where he was. Behind Matt, Lila had stopped with a dish towel in her hand.

Matt Shifflett. If you're that mad at me, say it to me. Holler at me if you want. What did that dog ever do? She was walking before you were born. She'll be walking when every one of us is gone.

It went out of him at once. He stepped down off the threshold. *I'm sorry,* he said to Plumb. *I had no call.*

It wasn't me you said it about, said Plumb. *Ask her.*

How do I do that?

Make three jars of flowers out of that stuff behind your house. We'll set them under the north sill. Then get yourself wet, clothes and hair, and ask.

Matt went to the shop and lit the torch. He called Wade, who was twelve. *I spoke ugly about the dog. I'm making these to set it right, and then I'm going to ask her pardon. I want you with me.*

I didn't make you say it, said Wade. *Go by yourself.*

He called Curtis, who was ten, and Curtis said the same.

He called Ben. Ben was eight. *If there's a thing to do, I guess I do it,* Ben said. He held the tongs. All that afternoon the two of them cut petals out of sheet gold and hammered them over a dowel. By dark they had three quart canning jars full of black-eyed Susans, each a hand across.

In the morning they carried the jars up to the brook. Plumb bedded them in the stones under the north sill and laid the log over them. Gone was sitting on the bank of the Swift below the bridge when Matt came down. He walked into the river in his boots and his wool shirt until it closed over his head. September water in that river will stop your breath. He came out with his hair streaming and stood in front of her and said what he had to say. Ben stood beside him.

She looked at him a while. Then she went down and drank.

People who knew how he had come into the world said the river had only been collecting early.

VII. The Barn

Starbird Falls · September 2025

He left in April with a pack Ben had weighed at twenty-two pounds. He rode a bus to Georgia and found her on Springer Mountain with eleven others. She smelled his hands. It is in the registers that whatever was left in him went out of him somewhere in the first week, on a wet day, going up Blood Mountain. By Virginia his hair had matted the way it had in the basin, and the trail called him Mats.

They went around the Smokies by the road, since dogs are not let through the park. They crossed the Shenandoah on a highway bridge in June. He looked down at the water once and went on.

In September they came down the road into Starbird Falls. The registers say five hundred. It was nearer sixty at any one time, with more arriving behind. They stopped at the door of the house under the hill. Wade came out, then Curtis, then Ben.

For half a month the three of them fed Gone's people. They set planks on sawhorses in the yard. There were baked beans, biscuits, corn, chow-

der and blueberry pie. Wade ran the grill and Curtis drove to Rumford for more of everything. Their father ate at the planks with the rest. He slept in Orrin's old barn with the rest too, and Ben brought him his plate the same as anyone's and did not call him anything but Mats where others could hear.

Above them the whole time stood the hill, a hundred and twenty feet of it, and in the evening it turned the color of the inside of a peach.

Hikers talk at night. On the tenth evening, in the barn, a young one called Receipt said what several had been thinking.

Mats. No offense. You sat all day under that thing. Your own three boys were carrying you pie. Tell the truth. You didn't want it back, even for a minute? You weren't a little bit proud?

No, Mats said. *I looked, to see. There wasn't either one.*

Come on.

Nobody's that clean, said another. *He's telling us what he wishes was so.*

There was a man in the company called Howdy. He said the same thing to every hiker he met, in either direction, *You're going to make it,* and he had been cursed for it on some bad climbs. He did not say it now. Everyone was looking at the dog.

It was known on the whole trail, from Georgia up, that Gone would not lie down beside anybody who was carrying. She would walk in front of you for a thousand miles. She would sit near you. But if you were holding on to a thing you had left, or a thing you meant to get, she kept on her feet.

She had been by the door. She got up and stretched. She crossed the barn floor through all of them and let herself down against Mats's legs, and laid her chin on his boot.

Nobody said anything for a time.

There was a book that traveled with her. It had been Footnote's, a paperback *Leaves of Grass* with every page cut away for weight but one poem, and since his time whoever walked nearest her had carried it in a bread bag. They called it the Dog's book. When she lay down by someone, the one who had it read. Howdy had it that month. He took it out and held it to the lantern.

Henceforth I ask not good-fortune, I myself am good-fortune,
Henceforth I whimper no more, postpone no more, need nothing,
Done with indoor complaints, libraries, querulous criticisms,
Strong and content I travel the open road.

You shall not heap up what is call'd riches,
You shall scatter with lavish hand all that you earn or achieve,

— Walt Whitman, Song of the Open Road 1, 11

Well, said Receipt, after a while. *All right.* He lay back on his pad and looked up into the rafters. Several of them said later that it was the night something of their own came loose.

VIII. The Line

Abol Bridge, Maine · October 2025

They went north in the morning. The three sons stood at the door. Ben lifted one hand, and his father lifted one, and that was all of it.

It is eighteen days from there to Abol Bridge, across the Kennebec in the ferryman's canoe and through the Hundred-Mile Wilderness. Past the bridge the trail goes into Baxter State Park and up Katahdin to the end, and at the park line there is a sign. No dogs.

She did what she had done every October since anyone had kept count. She sat down at the sign. The company went by her one at a time. Some put a hand on her head and some could not look at her. Howdy went by last and told her she was going to make it. Then they were all in the trees, climbing toward the thing they had walked two thousand miles for.

Mats had the book now, in its bread bag. He took off his pack and sat down next to her at the line. They stayed there until the last voice was gone up the mountain.

Then she stood and shook herself and turned around. There would be late ones south of them, still coming, with the snow not far off.

He followed her. The white mark on her chest was turned away from him now, but there was one on every tree.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who, leaving all longings, travels about without a home, and in whom all covetousness is extinct.*
>
> Dhammapada 416, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary's story of Jaṭila ("Matted Hair") is one of its longest. A rich man's daughter, kept at the top of a seven-story palace, bears a son to a sorcerer who flies in at her window, and sets the baby adrift on the Ganges in a new pot. Two women bathing claim the pot and its contents, and the king divides them. The woman who gets the child means him for the Elder Mahā Kaccāna, who sees that the boy must first be rich and leaves him with a merchant in distant Takkasilā. The boy sells twelve years of unsold stock in one day, marries the merchant's daughter, and steps into his new house as a mountain of gold eighty cubits high breaks out of the ground behind it. Years later, wanting to go forth, he sends men out with a gold brick, whip and cord to learn whether anyone is as rich; they find Meṇḍaka with his golden rams and Jotika, whose gate-sweeper is given a priceless blanket to wipe her feet. He tests his three sons with a spade at the mountain, and only the youngest can dig. The reason lies in a former life, when he told a monk collecting for a shrine to "throw your Teacher into the water," repented, and made three jars of golden flowers with only his youngest son to help. He becomes a monk; his sons feed the Buddha and the monks for half a month; the monks doubt that he feels no longing for the gold or his sons, and the Buddha answers them. Read the full commentary story. The long past-life histories of Jotika, which the commentary tells along the way, are kept here only as rumors heard at his gate, and the former-life quarrel is moved into Matt's own married years. On the elder who places the boy, see Mahā Kaccāna.

Starbird Falls (fictional), Oxford County, Maine

The trail and a Maine town, 1979 to 2025

The Appalachian Trail runs almost 2,200 miles from Springer Mountain in Georgia to Katahdin in Maine, marked the whole way by white paint blazes two inches wide and six inches tall. Each year a few thousand people set out to walk all of it. They take trail names, write in the notebooks ("registers") kept at the shelters, which in Maine are called lean-tos, and are fed along the way by strangers. Dogs may walk nearly all of the trail, but they are barred from Great Smoky Mountains National Park and from Baxter State Park, where the trail ends; the park boundary is just north of Abol Bridge, at the far side of the Hundred-Mile Wilderness. Hikers cross the Kennebec River by a canoe ferry.

Starbird Falls and its people are invented. The Swift River in Oxford County is real, and people do pan placer gold from it at Coos Canyon in Byron. The ice storm of January 1998 coated much of Maine, Oxford County included, in freezing rain in the second week of the month, and left more than half a million people in the state without power, some for two weeks or longer; stores sold out of kerosene heaters, lightbulbs and generators. Maine towns still govern themselves by annual town meeting, usually in March, voting one by one on the numbered articles of a warrant, each of which begins "To see if the Town will."

After the story of the Elder Jaṭila from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 416). The original. Verses from Walt Whitman, "Song of the Open Road," in *Leaves of Grass* (1891–92 edition). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.34

The White Disk

… having no particular home, but equally at home everywhere.
— Henry David Thoreau, "Walking"

Here is how I heard it, on the Nevada side.

I. The Stone Light

East shore of Lake Tahoe, Nevada · 1998

There was a house on the Nevada side with no lamp in it. It belonged to a man named Bright. The night he was born, in Carson City, every ring and watch and belt buckle in town gave off light, and the rifles in the sheriff's rack shone so that the deputy on duty read his paper by them. People said that was where the name came from, though it had been his father's name too.

When he was of an age to marry, a crew came to clear a lot for him above the public beach. A carpenter none of them knew walked onto the site and asked what they were doing. Then he told them to go home. *He won't live in anything you can build.* By morning the house stood there, seven stories of it, with seven walls around it and a gate in each wall. Nobody on the east shore has ever claimed the work.

The walls and floors were of stone so clear and so polished that they gave back the lake. There were stones in the ceilings that gave light, and the household ate and read by them. His wife came from the north. She never said how far, and it was understood to be past where there are roads or fences. She brought with her a quart pot of rice and three stones the size of goose eggs. A pan set on those stones got hot, and when the food was done they cooled. In all the years of that house nobody saw the bottom of the pot. Anybody who came to the first gate hungry was fed

from it, and anybody who came short was sent off with what he needed. For some summers there were so many cars on the shoulder of the highway that the county put up signs.

In June of 1998 Bim Sayer came to breakfast. Bim owned the Regent at Stateline, eleven hundred rooms, and on that end of the lake he was as near to a king as Nevada allows. He brought his boy, A.J., who was seven and held on to one of his father's fingers.

A woman sweeping at the first gate put out her hand to help him over the sill. Bim took her for Mrs. Bright and would not touch her. Inside, the floor was so clear that he saw a hundred feet of drop under his shoes, and he stopped.

You've dug me a pit, Bright.

There's no pit. Walk where I walk.

So the owner of the Regent crossed the hall in another man's steps, with his boy behind him.

They ate on the top floor. Bright sent word down to his wife that Mr. Sayer was at the table.

Who is Mr. Sayer?

He owns the south end. You could say he's over us.

She was a while answering. *I didn't know anybody was over us,* she said. *We must have done something by halves, somewhere back.* But she came up and stood by Bim's chair, and after a minute tears were running down her face.

She's afraid I'll take the place, Bim said. *Tell her I don't want it.*

She isn't crying, said Bright. *It's the smoke in your coat. She has never sat by a lamp or a fire. You came here off your casino floor.* When they left he gave Bim one of the stones, to read by.

The boy had looked at the ceilings through the whole meal. *My father is a fool,* he thought. *He's the king and he lives in sheetrock. When it's mine, this man doesn't stay here one day.*

II. The First Gate

The same shore · August 2025

In March of 2025 A.J. Sayer and a lawyer named Devlin had the old man found unfit to manage his affairs. They put him in a locked unit in Carson City, and A.J. signed for who went in to him and what went in with them. Bim Sayer died there in June. He weighed a hundred and nine pounds. One nurse said he had stopped eating. Another said, once, and afterward would not say it again, that the trays had stopped coming.

By August the Regent was A.J.'s, and he remembered the breakfast.

He came up the shore road on a Tuesday morning with eleven black Suburbans. He had forty men. Some were lawyers and some were the kind the casino kept for other work, and those were armed. He had a locksmith. He had a paper Devlin had drawn up, which did not need to be good.

The outer wall of Bright's place ran along the highway for a quarter mile. A.J. came around the last curve and saw eleven black cars and forty men coming at him out of the stone. He put his foot on the brake.

He's got his own, he said. *He knew. He's got as many as we have.*

The column sat on the shoulder with the engines running, facing itself.

Then the woman at the first gate came out. Her name was Mrs. Coley. She had swept that gatehouse for thirty years, and she still had the broom in her hand.

Where are you going? she said.

Nobody who was there has explained the next part well. She was one woman past seventy with a push broom. Forty men went up the highway and down the highway and into the manzanita, and two went into the lake in their shoes. The Suburbans stood on the shoulder with their doors open until dark.

A.J. ran downhill. He came out at the pier in Zephyr Cove, where the Regent kept a boat, and he took it straight out for the middle of the lake, as a man does who wants nothing near him on any side.

III. Twenty Rings

Mid-lake · the same morning

There was one thing out there, and it was the university's boat.

The university has kept a record of how clear the lake is since 1968. Every couple of weeks, the year round, the boat goes out to the same two stations. Somebody lowers a white disk the size of a dinner plate on a marked line and watches it down. The depth where you lose it gets written in the log. Then you bring it up until you have it again, and that gets written, and the number halfway between is the reading. In the first years it averaged ninety-seven feet. In 2024 it was sixty-two.

For thirty-six of those years the hand on the line had been Peg Ostrander's. She was a field technician, sixty-three years old. She had outlasted three directors, and she answered most questions with the number.

Bright had been riding along on reading days for eleven years. He had come the first time to ask whether the lake was getting brighter or darker, and she had handed him the logbook. After that he drove around to Tahoe City on those mornings, straight from breakfast, paid for the diesel and sat on the stern locker. While the disk was down Peg would say a sentence or two to whoever was aboard. It was mostly about not wanting the number to be anything. *You lose it where you lose it,* she said. He came to hear that as other people go to church.

They were on station with the engine off and the disk down when the Regent's boat came across the flat water. A.J. cut his engine and stood up in it.

Bright. You set your people on me, and here you sit like a man in a pew.

Bright got up off the locker. *What's happened to you, A.J.?* Then he looked at him a little longer. *Did you go up there to take the house?*

That's what I went for.

A thousand of you couldn't take that house if I didn't want it taken.

What are you now? You figure to run this lake?

No. I don't want to run anything. But there isn't a man alive, you or a thief, who takes one thread off my cuff unless I've let go of it.

A.J. thought about that. *Then let go of it. Give it to me.*

Bright held up his hands. He wore two rings on every finger, and nobody on that boat had ever asked him why. *Here are twenty rings. I'm not giving them to you. Come and get them.*

A.J. stepped across the two rails. He was thirty-four and lifted weights every morning. He took hold of the outside ring on Bright's left little finger and pulled. He set his feet and hauled. He crouched and jumped with both hands on it and went up twenty-seven feet, higher than the antenna, and came down still holding on. He jumped again and went up a hundred and twenty. Tess, the graduate student keeping the log that day, wrote both figures in the margin, since she did not know what else to do with them. The ring had not gone over the knuckle.

Hold out your jacket, said Bright.

A.J. held it out by the hem. Bright straightened his fingers, and twenty rings slid off and dropped into the cloth in a small heap.

You see how it is, Bright said.

A.J. stood looking down into the jacket. Then he looked at Bright's bare hands to see what was left on them. Bright watched him do it. They say on the boat that this was what turned him, more than the cars at his wall, more even than the old man in Carson City. He had seen a grown man with his coat full look for more.

A.J., I want to go.

Go where?

Off it. Out from under all of it. You're what there is for a king on this end of the lake, so I'm asking you. Give me leave.

A.J. worked it out where he stood. With Bright gone, the house was a job for a locksmith.

Go, he said.

Peg had not looked up through any of this. *Fifty-nine and a half,* she said, and Tess wrote it down.

IV. Sixty-One

Lake Tahoe · September 2025

He did not go back up the shore road. He walked off the dock at Tahoe City that afternoon in what he had on. The lake has seventy-two miles of shore, and he slept on some part of it, a different part most nights, and ate what he was handed. On reading days he was at the dock before the crew.

On the second trip Peg gave him the line. *Don't help it,* she said. That was all the instruction there was. Everybody helps it at first. You know about where it went last time, and you see it a foot longer than it can be seen.

On the nineteenth of September he let the disk down over the shaded side. He watched it go from white to a greenish white, and then to something he was not sure of, and then he was sure it was gone, and he said so. He brought it up until it was there again.

Sixty-one, he said. He had not wanted it to be anything.

When he raised his head the east shore had changed. Where the wall had been there was granite and manzanita and a stand of Jeffrey pine, with the highway in plain sight behind. A.J. had been up there twice that month with the locksmith and been turned back at the first gate. The third time there was no gate. They stood on bare rock with Devlin's paper. A.J. still has the twenty rings, and it is said that not one of them will go over his knuckle.

In the same hour a floatplane came in low out of the north and set down off the point. Mrs. Bright walked out on the rocks with the quart pot under her arm and the three stones tied in a dish towel. Somebody reached down a hand and she went aboard. No flight plan was filed in either state. Mrs. Coley went home to Gardnerville and took her blanket with her.

Peg looked at the shore, and then at the logbook.

Sixty-one, she said. *Write it.*

Tess waited until they were tied up.

Mr. Bright. Do you miss it? The house? Her?

No, he said.

She took that to Peg in the wheelhouse. *That isn't true, Peg. He may think it is. Nobody has all that and loses it in one afternoon and says no like that.*

I've caught every one of you reading it long, Peg said. *You twice. I've done it myself. You want a good year, so you see a good year. I stood next to him today, and he read it where it was.*

It was the most she had said at one time all season. Above the depth sounder two strips of paper were taped to the bulkhead. The technician before her had typed them in 1971, and the tape had gone the color of tea. She put her finger on them, and Tess read them out.

> *If you are ready to leave father and mother, and brother and sister, and wife and child and friends, and never see them again,—if you have paid your debts, and made your will, and settled all your affairs, and are a free man; then you are ready for a walk.*
>
> *... having no particular home, but equally at home everywhere.*
>
> *— Henry David Thoreau, "Walking"*

Tess read it over again to herself.

Out on the dock Bright had the disk in the rinse bucket. He hung it on its nail by the wheelhouse door, where it dripped for a while, and went up the ramp toward the road.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who, leaving all longings, travels about without a home, and in whom all covetousness is extinct.*
>
> Dhammapada 416, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary hangs two stories on this one verse. The first is Jaṭila's, and this is the second. The rich man Jotika ("the radiant one") lives in a jeweled palace that the god Sakka raised for him, with seven walls and a yakkha at each gate. His wife was brought to him from Uttarakuru, the northern continent where nothing is owned,

with one pot of rice that never runs out and three crystals that cook it, and the household lives by the light of gems and has never seen a lamp. When King Bimbisāra comes to see the palace, the little prince Ajātasattu walks beside him holding his finger and decides that when he is king this householder will not keep it. Years later Ajātasattu, with Devadatta's help, has his father killed. He marches on the palace, takes his own reflection in the walls for a defending army, and is routed by the yakkha of the first gate. He flees to the monastery, where Jotika is spending the Observance Day listening to the Buddha. Jotika tells him that a thousand kings could not take a thread from him against his will, and offers the twenty rings on his ten fingers. The king leaps eighteen cubits and then eighty and cannot pull one off. Jotika straightens his fingers and they fall into the king's robe. Then, shaken by what he has seen, he asks the king's leave to go forth. He becomes an arahat, his wealth vanishes, and the gods take his wife back to Uttarakuru. When the monks doubt that he feels no longing, the Buddha answers with the verse. Read the full commentary story. The palace and the king's first visit are told inside the story before it. On the king, see Ajātasattu, and on the wife's country, Uttarakuru.

Lake Tahoe, Nevada

Lake Tahoe and the white disk, 1968 to 2025

Lake Tahoe lies across the California and Nevada line at more than six thousand feet, with seventy-two miles of shoreline, about a third of it in Nevada. The hotel-casinos stand at the south end, in Stateline, and the east shore above them has long been a place of large private estates behind walls. The Sayers, the Regent, Mr. Bright and his house are invented.

The disk is real. A Secchi disk, named for the Italian astronomer who devised it in 1865, is a plain white plate lowered on a line; the depth at which it can no longer be seen is the measure of the water's clarity. The University of California, Davis has taken that measurement at Lake Tahoe since 1968, with a ten-inch disk, from a research boat, at a long-term station and a mid-lake station, some twenty to thirty times a year. The average for 1967 to 1971 was 97.4 feet, which is still the restoration

target. The 2024 average was 62.3 feet. Peg Ostrander and her crew are invented, as are the strips over the depth sounder. The words on them are from Thoreau's essay "Walking," printed in the *Atlantic Monthly* in June 1862, a month after he died, in which he derives "sauntering" from *sans terre*, without land or a home.

After the story of the Elder Jotika from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 416). The original. Words from Henry David Thoreau, "Walking" (1862). Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.35

The Sway Pole

> *Stand fast therefore in the liberty wherewith Christ hath made us free, and be not entangled again with the yoke of bondage.*
> *— Galatians 5:1*

Так я слыхал, in the Flats.

I. The Lot

The Flats, Los Angeles · 1919–1921

Vasily Novikoff was the boy who climbed things. He came over from the Kars country in his mother's arms in 1908, when he was two, and by the time he was nine he had been to the top of everything in the Flats that would hold a boy. He went up the lumber stacks at the yard on Alameda Street where his father drove a team, and walked the ridge of the planing-mill roof with his arms out. He went up the telephone poles on Utah Street by the spikes and sat on the crossbar with his feet hanging and watched the river. The year he was eleven he went up the water tank by the railroad tracks and stood on the rim of it in the wind, and a railroad bull pulled him down by the ankle, and he went before the juvenile court with a great many other Russian boys that year and stood there with his cap in his hands while the judge talked to his father through a girl from the Bethlehem Institutions who could interpret.

His father was Pavel Novikoff, a big, quiet man who had driven freight wagons over the mountain roads between Kars and Erzurum, and who in Los Angeles drove a lumber dray for four dollars a day and came home too tired to eat. His mother was Avdotya. She baked bread on Saturdays for the whole street and on Sundays put a clean shirt on Vasya and a rope

belt around it and walked him to sobranie on Clarence Street, morning and afternoon, where the men sat on one side on long benches and the women on the other side in their white kerchiefs and lace, and the elders sat at the table at the front with the Bible on a white cloth, and everybody sang. They sang the psalms in the long old melodies, so slow that a boy could forget which word they were on. And when the Spirit came down on the meeting, the people rose, and the old men and old women lifted their hands and went up off the floor in little jumps, light as children, and the boards shook. Vasya watched them do it from the bench. It looked to him like the beginning of something that nobody ever finished.

In the spring of 1921 a carnival set up on a lot down by the river. It had a merry-go-round and a ten-in-one and a cookhouse, and in the middle of the lot it had a pole. It was steel tube, ninety feet, set in a socket in the ground and stayed with four wires halfway up, and the top half was left free so that it would bend. Every night at nine o'clock the band played and an old man in white tights climbed to the top of it by a rope ladder and stood up there on a little plate, and then, slowly, he began to sway. He leaned and the pole leaned with him, out over the crowd, farther than you would believe a pole could go, until the people under it backed away screaming and laughing, and then it went back the other way, out over the merry-go-round, and back, and back, the arc getting longer each time, and the old man at the top of it standing on one foot with his arms out as if he were walking somewhere in the sky.

His name was Garnier. His people had been on the rope in this country since before the Revolution, he said, and one of them had danced on a ship's topmast at Newport in Rhode Island and then gone off and married into the Quakers, and the family had never got over it. He said it as if the Quakers were a kind of drowning.

Vasya went down to the lot three nights running. On the fourth night, after the crowd had gone, he went up the ladder in the dark. Garnier found him at the top of it, on the plate, with his knees bent, feeling the pole move under him in the little night wind off the river.

Well, come down, said the old man from the foot of the ladder. *You'll want to learn it properly.*

When the carnival went north up the valley to Bakersfield, Vasya went with it. He left a note on the table for his mother, written in the Russian letters she had taught him, under the edge of the bread.

II. The Pictures

The road, and Culver City · 1921–1935

Garnier taught him for five years. He taught him the ladder and the plate and the handstand on the plate, and the slide for life down the long wire to the ground, and he taught him the sway. That was the whole of it, the old man said. A pole will carry you if you let it. You lean, it comes with you. You go out to the end and it bends and slows, and at the very end of the arc there is a moment when it has stopped going out and has not yet started back, and in that moment you weigh nothing at all. Nobody in the crowd can see it. Only the one at the top knows it is there. *That's what they pay you for,* Garnier said, *and they don't even know they're paying for it.*

They played county fairs from Phoenix to Klamath Falls, Fresno and Salinas and Tulare and Yakima, and the free act was the thing that brought the crowd onto the lot. When the old man's hands began to shake, Vasya took the pole himself. The bills said BILL NOVAK, THE HUMAN COMET, and he went up it every night in white tights with a spangled sash around his waist, and the people backed away screaming under him the way they had for Garnier. In the winter of 1926 Garnier died in his bed in a rooming house in Riverside, and left Vasya the pole and the sash.

A man from one of the studios saw the act at the Pomona fair and gave him a card. After that it was the pictures. He did high falls into nets and into water tanks and once into a pile of cardboard boxes behind a bank on a back lot, and saddle falls out at the movie ranch in Chatsworth, and he went from one roof to another in comedies with his coat flying, doubling for men whose names were on the theater fronts on Broadway. He got fifty dollars for a fall that took one afternoon, when his father was making four dollars a day at the yard. He drove a cream-colored Packard.

He shaved every morning and oiled his hair, and the girls at the commissary called him Bill.

He sent money home in envelopes. His mother did not open them. She put them in the drawer of the table under the cloth, in a stack, with the stamps still on, because she did not know what was right to do with money that came from the picture shows, and his father would not touch them. When his father died in the winter of 1931, Vasya was on location in Utah, standing on a red cliff in another man's hat, and the telegram reached him four days after the burial.

III. Come Down

Clarence Street · March 1935

His mother died in March of 1935, in her bed on Utah Street, of the dropsy, with the neighbor women around her. This time the telegram came in time. He drove in from Culver City in the Packard in a camel-hair coat, and parked it in the street in front of the house, where the little boys stood around it and would not touch it.

They had laid her out in the front room in her white kerchief, and all that night the singers sat with her and sang. Vasya did not go in. He stood outside the door in the dark yard with his hat in his hands, a clean-shaven man in a good coat among men with beards, and the brothers who came and went nodded to him and did not say anything. Through the door he could hear the old men leading and the others coming in behind them, the long notes going up and holding and coming down, and after midnight he heard old Lukyan Ivanovich lead a psalm he remembered from the bench when he was five years old, and the whole room took it up.

> *Душа наша избавилась, как птица, из сети ловящих: сеть расторгнута, и мы избавились.*
>
> *Our soul is escaped as a bird out of the snare of the fowlers: the snare is broken, and we are escaped.*
>
> *— Psalm 124:7 (Synodal 123:7; King James Version)*

Lukyan Ivanovich Sysoev was past eighty. He had driven a team over the mountains with Pavel Novikoff in the old country, and hauled lumber beside him on Alameda Street for twenty years, and now he was the presbyter of the little sobranie on Clarence Street, chosen by the brothers, because he spoke so seldom that when he did they listened. His beard came down to his belt and was as white as the tablecloth. He walked with a stick cut from a eucalyptus in Hollenbeck Park.

They buried Avdotya in the morning at the cemetery out past the city line, and came back to the Flats for the meal. The tables were set end to end in the sobranie with the backless benches along them, and the bread laid right on the cloth the way it was always done, and the women carried in borshch and lapsha and stewed beef and compote. Vasya sat at the end of a bench. He did not eat. When the meal was over he went up the room to where Lukyan Ivanovich sat at the head table, and took out a roll of bills with a rubber band around it, and held it out.

For the dinner, he said. *For the singing. Whatever it costs.*

The old man looked at the money and then at him. He put out his big dry hand, the hand of a man who had held reins for fifty years, and closed Vasya's fingers back over the roll and pushed it toward him until it was against his coat.

Then what do I owe? said Vasya. *Tell me what I owe.*

Nothing, said Lukyan Ivanovich. *Come down.*

He said *слезай*, the word you call up to a boy in a tree. Then he turned back to the man beside him, and that was all.

• • •

Vasya drove back to Culver City that afternoon. On Monday he was called for a fall from a water tower on the back lot. He went up the ladder in another man's clothes, and at the top, with the camera crew small on the ground below him and the director lifting his megaphone, he heard it, the one word, the way you remember a word. He stood on the rim of the tower a while in the wind. Then he turned around and came down the ladder, rung by rung, the slow way, and walked past the director and the crew and out the gate, and did not go back.

He sold the Packard. He took the money from it and the roll of bills and the stack of unopened envelopes from his mother's table drawer, and gave all of it to the brothers on Clarence Street for the widows, who were many that year. He let his beard grow. He went to work on a rubbish route with Semyon Kalugin, who had a truck and a city contract and no son old enough to help him, and they went out before light every morning through the alleys of Boyle Heights, hauling ashes and cans and newspapers, the work other men would not do in the Depression because they were too proud. On Sunday he put on a clean shirt and a rope belt and walked to sobranie, morning and afternoon. Lukyan Ivanovich motioned him to the singers' bench. Vasya said he could not sing.

Sit there, said the old man. *Open your mouth.*

IV. The Top of the Swing

The Flats · 1935–1937

The young men of the sobranie watched him. Most of them had been to the picture shows on Brooklyn Avenue on Saturday nights against their fathers' wishes, and some of them had seen him fall off a roof in a black coat with his arms out and had not known it was him. They asked him about the stars, at first, the cowboys and the comedians. He said they were men like other men. They asked him what the pole was like, up there at the top. He said it was very high.

What they watched most was what he did when the Spirit came. Everybody knew that the Spirit came on the meeting in its own time, and when it came the people rose, and the old men went up in their little jumps, and the women, and sometimes a young man would go up so high and so long, his hands in the air, that the elders would stop singing to watch him. The young men waited for Vasily Novikoff to do it. A man who could stand on one foot at the top of a ninety-foot pole in a wind would jump in the Spirit, surely, so that the whole Flats would hear about it. And he did not. When the hall rose and the boards began to shake, Vasya rose too, and lifted his hands, and went up a little on his toes, the way old Lukyan did, and that was all. Some of the young men said he was cold.

Others said he was saving it, the way a performer does, for the night when it would count.

It came to him in the summer of 1935, on a Sunday morning in July, in the middle of the meeting, and nobody saw it but the old man at the table.

The Spirit had come down. The whole room was up, the singing loud and broken, the benches walking on the floor, a woman near the window crying out in a voice like a bird. Vasya was standing with the others with his hands lifted, and as he stood there it came on him, the thing he had known only at the top of the swing. It was the moment at the very end of the arc, when the pole has stopped going out and has not yet started back, and you weigh nothing. He had known it a thousand times, for the space of a breath, ninety feet in the air. Now he knew it standing on the floor of the sobranie on Clarence Street with the boards shaking under him, and it did not end. He did not go up and he did not come down. He stood in the middle of the jumping with his eyes open and his hands at his sides and was perfectly still, and the room went on around him like weather.

Lukyan Ivanovich, at the table, looked up from under his white eyebrows and saw his face, and looked at it a long time, and then looked down again at the Bible on the cloth.

Vasya never spoke of it. But the women on the other side of the hall said afterward that something had happened to the Novikoff boy that summer, because he slept now, and laughed easily, and had stopped looking at the sky.

V. The Free Act

Mission Road · a Sunday in October 1937

That fall the Agafonoffs, out in Karakala, had a new son, and on the third Sunday of October the whole sobranie walked out from Clarence Street after morning meeting to bless him and to eat at their table. They went the way they always went, in a long slow file up the hill and along the streets, the old men in front, the women behind with

THEIR KERCHIEFS BRIGHT IN THE SUN, THE YOUNG MEN STRAGgling at the back. Lukyan Ivanovich walked at the head of them with his eucalyptus stick, and the singers sang as they walked, so that people came out on their porches along the way to see the Russians go by.

On a vacant lot off Mission Road a carnival had come in. It had a Ferris wheel and a merry-go-round and a cookhouse that smelled of onions and hot grease, and a banner over the gate that said BIG SUNSET SHOWS, and in the middle of the lot it had a pole. It was taller than Garnier's had been, a hundred and ten feet at least, painted silver and red in a spiral, and stayed with wires halfway up. A boy in white tights was at the top of it, and the band was playing, and the crowd under him was the crowd of every Sunday on the east side, Mexican families in their good clothes, Jewish boys from Brooklyn Avenue in sweaters, Japanese girls with their hair cut short, a policeman with his cap pushed back.

The boy at the top began to sway.

The file of Russians slowed. The old men went on walking, but the young men stopped at the edge of the lot and stood in a bunch and looked up, and some of the women looked too, behind their hands. The boy went out over the crowd, and the crowd backed away screaming, and the pole bent like a buggy whip, and he went back the other way, out over the merry-go-round, and back. At the end of every swing he stood on one foot with his arms out. Then he did a headstand on the plate, and the pole went out with him upside down at the top of it, and a girl in the crowd covered her eyes.

Mitya Kalugin was nineteen, Semyon's eldest. He fell back beside Vasya, and Fedya Sorokin and Grisha Babin came with him, and the three of them walked along at his elbow with their faces turned up.

Vasya, said Mitya. *Look at him. That's what you did, isn't it? That exact thing.*

That's it, said Vasya.

And you don't want it? You don't miss it at all, up there?

Vasya looked up at the boy on the pole. He looked for a while, the way he would have looked at a hawk or a cloud. Then he said, *No, brothers,* and

went on walking after the old men, and after a moment, not knowing what else to do, the three young men followed him.

At the Agafonoffs' they sang over the baby and ate at long tables in the yard under a pepper tree, lapsha and bread and watermelon. All through the meal the three of them watched him. They watched him eat his soup and talk with old Marfa Agafonova about her tomatoes. Over the roofs, the band at the carnival lot could be heard starting up again for the four o'clock show, and they watched his face when it started, and it did not change.

He's lying, said Grisha under his breath, on the walk home.

Fourteen years, said Fedya. *Fifty dollars a fall. Nobody stops wanting that.*

You saw him look up, said Mitya. *You saw how long he looked.*

VI. The Yoke

Clarence Street · Monday evening

On Monday, after the trucks were in, the three young men went to see Lukyan Ivanovich. Old Ivan Stepanovich Popoff went with them, because the young men had told him, and he agreed it was a serious thing. A lie spoken among the brothers was a sin, and a man who had come back from the picture shows had to be watched more carefully than other men. That was only right.

The old man was sitting in his yard behind the house on an upturned crate, in the last of the light, with a set of harness across his knees. It had belonged to the gray horse he drove for twenty years on Alameda Street, and the horse was long dead and he had no wagon, but every so often he took the harness down from its nail and oiled it. He did not look up. He went on working the oil into the leather with his thumb while they told him. Mitya did most of the talking. He told about the carnival and the pole and the boy on top, and what they had asked and what Vasya had answered.

He said no, said Mitya. *He said it to our faces. He did that for fourteen years, Lukyan Ivanovich. He was famous. A man doesn't do a thing like that for fourteen years and then stop wanting it. He said what isn't so.*

He should be spoken to, said Ivan Stepanovich. *Before the brothers.*

Lukyan Ivanovich oiled the length of a trace to the end of it. Then he hung it over his knee and looked at them.

My son, he said, *has come out from under every yoke there is.*

They waited. He did not usually say more, and they did not expect it. But he moved the harness a little on his knee, the collar and the hames and the long reins, and laid his hand on it.

The pictures had a yoke on him, he said. *The crowd had a yoke on him. The money. He put those down. You all saw him put those down. And there is one you can wear in the sobranie, too, with your hands in the air. Wanting to go up. You've watched him when the Spirit comes. He doesn't want up anymore. Up and down are all one to him now.* He looked at Mitya. *He looked at that boy on the pole the way I look at this harness. You can look at a thing a long time without wanting to put it on.*

Then, because the young men were still standing there and the light was going, he said the verse, the way he said it in meeting, from memory, with his eyes shut.

> *Итак стойте в свободе, которую даровал нам Христос, и не подвергайтесь опять игу рабства.*
>
> *Stand fast therefore in the liberty wherewith Christ hath made us free, and be not entangled again with the yoke of bondage.*
>
> *— Galatians 5:1 (Synodal; King James Version)*

Mitya Kalugin stood in the old man's yard a long time after the others had gone. He was thinking about the boy at the top of the pole, and about how high his own face had been turned, and for how long. He was thinking about Saturday nights on Brooklyn Avenue, and the dark of the picture show, and a man in a black coat falling off a roof with his arms out, and how he had felt watching it. It came to him that the longing they had gone to report had been their own, all three of them, and that they had carried it up Clarence Street in their arms like a sick child to set it down in front of the one man in the Flats who did not have it. It was not a comfortable thing to know. He knew it anyway. Fedya and Grisha came to

know it in their own time, and Ivan Stepanovich, who was sixty-one and had never been inside a picture show in his life, said later that it had been a lesson to him as well, though he would not say about what.

• • •

The carnival tore down on Tuesday night and went north. On Thursday the lot off Mission Road was on Semyon Kalugin's route, and Semyon was sick, so Vasya drove, and Mitya rode on the running board.

The lot was trampled flat and white with paper. They went over it with rakes and forks and loaded what the carnival had left, the paper cups and peanut shells and torn tickets, a burned-out bulb from the Ferris wheel, a pennant on a stick, a child's shoe. In the middle of the lot was the place where the pole had stood. There was a round hole there as deep as a man's arm, where the socket had been set, and four stake holes around it where the guy wires had been pinned, and the dirt around them was beaten hard by a week of feet.

Vasya stood and looked at it, and Mitya watched him look.

Then Vasya took the shovel off the truck. He filled the hole from the loose dirt at its edge, and filled the four stake holes, one after another, and walked round and round on the fill, tamping it down with his heel the way you would tamp the dirt around a fence post, until there was nothing to show where anything had been. He scraped the shovel clean on the edge of the truck bed and threw it up on the load. Then he wiped his hands on his trousers, and got in behind the wheel, and waited with the engine running for Mitya to climb on.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who, after leaving all bondage to men, has risen above all bondage to the gods, and is free from all and every bondage.*
>
> Dhammapada 417, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, an acrobat who performs from place to place hears the Buddha teach, goes forth as a monk, and soon becomes an arahat. One day, walking into the village for alms with the whole community of monks behind the Buddha, the monks see another acrobat going through the same act he used to do, and ask him whether he still longs for that life. He says he does not. The monks go to the Buddha and accuse him of speaking falsely. The Buddha answers that his son has passed beyond all bonds, and speaks the verse, which in the Pāli speaks of a human yoke, a divine yoke, and freedom from every yoke. The commentary tells the same story again word for word for the next verse (418), where the Buddha says instead that the monk has left behind both delight and discontent. The series met an earlier acrobat, Uggasena, in Cloud of Witnesses. Read the full commentary story.

Boyle Heights, Los Angeles, California

The Flats, 1937

Between about 1904 and the early 1910s some thousands of Molokans and related Spiritual Christians left Transcaucasia, many from the Kars region, and settled on the east side of Los Angeles. Most of the Los Angeles families were Pryguny, or "Jumpers," whose worship includes leaping when the Holy Spirit is felt to descend. Refusal of military service was one of their chief reasons for leaving Russia, and during the First World War dozens of Molokan men in the United States went to jail for defying the draft. They kept no icons and no priests, chose elders to lead their meetings (sobranie), sang psalms in long unwritten melodies, and ate no pork. The first neighborhood was "the Flats," on the low ground along the east bank of the Los Angeles River below Boyle Heights. The men worked in lumber yards and mills, and in the Depression many took up city rubbish routes. Their elders worried that the picture shows were pulling their children away, and many families moved out toward Karakala and East Los Angeles in the 1920s and '30s.

Hollywood's stunt trade grew out of rodeo and the circus. Cowboys like Yakima Canutt did falls and horse work in westerns, while acrobats and high divers took the falls from roofs and towers in comedies and thrillers. On the carnival lots and at

county fairs, the "free act" that drew crowds onto the midway was often a high act, such as a high dive into a tank or a sway pole, a tall flexible pole that the performer bent far out over the crowd from a small platform at the top. One of the best known, Arzeno Selden, "the Stratosphere Man," built himself a sway pole 175 feet tall and toured carnivals and fairs with it until a fall in Florida ended his life in 1951.

After the story of the elder who had been an acrobat, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 417). The original. Scripture from the Russian Synodal Bible (1876) and the King James Version. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.36

Plain Stone

> *Be still and cool in thy own mind and spirit from thy own thoughts…*
> *— George Fox, letter to Lady Claypole (1658)*

As it was told me, in Washington Square.

I. The Last Garnier

The road, and Newport · 1966–2011

Jo Garnier was born in a trailer behind the grandstand of the Ionia Free Fair in Michigan in July of 1966, between the two shows her father did each night on the sway pole. Her people had been on the rope in this country since before the Revolution, and her father liked to say so to the fair boards, and to add that one of them, back at the start, had danced on a ship's mast at Newport in Rhode Island and then run off and married a Quaker, and that the family had never got over it. He said it as a joke. It was the only story about the family that everyone in it knew.

She was on the wire at six and on the pole at sixteen, when her father's back went. She worked the fairs with the family until there were no more fairs that hired a free act, and then she went to New York and flew for the one-ring circus in the tent at Lincoln Center, and then for the big Canadian shows, in Las Vegas and on tour, for fifteen years. She was a flyer and then a catcher and then, when her knees began to go, she went back to what she had started on and did a slack-wire act thirty feet up, alone, in a white leotard, that the papers in Montreal called the stillest thing in the show. In Phoenix in 2005 a rigging plate failed and she fell twenty-six feet onto the edge of the net and broke her pelvis in two

places. She was back up on the wire in nine months. Three years after that she came down for good, and nobody, including her, could have said exactly why.

She came to Newport because of the joke. She was forty-two and had no other place in particular, and she wanted to see the town where the girl on the mast had come down. She stood a long time on Washington Square in front of the old Colony House, in the traffic, trying to work out where a mast would have stood. Then she went looking for the Quakers, and found that the great meetinghouse on Farewell Street was a museum now and the meeting that was left met on First Days in a borrowed parish room on the Point, nine or ten people in a circle of folding chairs. She sat with them that Sunday, an hour without a word, and came back the next week, and the next.

She needed work, and a man at the meeting knew a stone shop on Spring Street that had been cutting gravestones in Newport for four generations of the same family and had never had enough people with steady hands. She swept the shop for a year. Then they gave her a mallet and a chisel and a slab of slate to practice on, and found out that she could stand at a stone for six hours and not move anything but one wrist. She was taken into membership in 2011. By 2024 she was fifty-eight and lettered half the stones that went out of that shop, and in meeting she almost never spoke.

The one she sat nearest to on First Days was Walt Pearce. He was eighty-eight, a retired engineer who had spent thirty-five years at the sonar plant in Portsmouth listening to tapes of the sea, and he spoke in meeting perhaps twice a year, and when he did, the others said, it was worth the wait. The first year she came she had asked him, after meeting, what you were supposed to do for the hour. He thought about it. *Same as up there, I'd guess,* he said. *Only don't do anything.* It was the only instruction she ever had.

II. Washington Square

Newport · a First Day in August 2024

Once a year, in August, the historical society let the meeting hold worship in the old house on Farewell Street, the great meetinghouse of 1699 where the Friends of all New England had gathered every summer for two hundred years. The meeting walked there together from the Point, the eleven of them who were left and a few summer attenders, the long way, through town, because Walt liked to go by the water. He went in front with his cane. Jo walked at the back with Abby Sherman, who was twenty-four and home from graduate school, and Abby's friend Dana, a counselor from Providence who had been attending since the spring.

Washington Square was full of the Sunday crowd off the cruise ship, and in the middle of it, in front of the Colony House, a troupe of street acrobats from Montreal had strung a slack wire between two steel tripods and set up a speaker. A boy was walking the wire in sneakers, and then a girl went up after him in a white leotard and stood on it with no hands, and lay down on it on her back, and stood up again, and rocked it, side to side, slowly, in the long swings that make the crowd under a wire draw in its breath. The tourists had their phones up. A man in a captain's hat said *Holy cow* out loud.

The meeting slowed. Walt kept going. Abby looked at the wire and then at Jo.

Jo. That's what you did. Isn't it? That exact thing.

That's it, said Jo.

Don't you miss it? Even a little? Standing there watching?

Jo looked up at the girl on the wire. She looked a long time, the way she looked at a piece of slate before she drew on it, to see where the grain ran. Then she said, *No, I don't,* and went on after Walt, and Abby and Dana came behind.

They talked about it on Spring Street in low voices. Abby thought it could not be true. Thirty-six years, she said, she'd done that since she was six, she had been the stillest thing in the show, nobody walks away from

that and doesn't miss it. She's being polite. She doesn't want to make a thing of it in front of us.

Dana thought it was the other way. *She fell,* Dana said. *She told me about it once. Twenty-six feet. I'd bet you anything she can't stand to look at it. When people say no that fast, it usually means it hurts.*

Either way, they agreed, it was not quite the truth, and among Friends that is not a small matter. Before they reached Farewell Street they had caught up with Walt and told him.

III. The Old House

The Great Friends Meeting House · the same forenoon

Walt did not say anything to them on the street. He went up the steps and in, and sat down on the front of the old benches facing the room, where the ministers had sat in the old days, because his knees would not take the gallery stairs, and the others sat down where they liked in the wide plain room under the beams, and the door was shut, and it was quiet.

It was quiet a long time. The traffic went by outside on Farewell Street. The benches were the same benches. Jo sat by a window with her hands open on her knees, and if anything was going on in her it did not show. Abby looked at her and then at the floor. Dana looked at the clock.

Toward the end of the hour Walt stood up. He stood with both hands on the head of his cane, and the old benches creaked all through the house as people leaned to listen, the way they say those benches always creaked when somebody rose who did not rise often.

Friends, he said. *I was told this morning that one of us said what isn't so. I was told she must want a thing she gave up. Or she must hate it, and won't say. I don't believe it's either. I've sat next to her thirteen years. She's put down the wanting, and she's put down the not wanting, both, and what's left isn't anything you'd notice in a crowd. It's cool, is what it is. Like the water out past Brenton Reef, down on the bottom, where nothing moves it. I used to listen to that water for a living.* He stopped. Then he said a little of George Fox, from memory, the way the old ones used to.

> *Be still and cool in thy own mind and spirit from thy own thoughts, and then thou wilt feel the principle of God to turn thy mind to the Lord, from whom cometh life; whereby thou mayest receive his strength and power to allay all storms, and tempests.*
>
> *— George Fox, letter to Lady Claypole (1658)*

He sat down. After a while he said, still sitting, as if it had just come back to him, *The same letter says when we go wrong, the mind flies up in the air.* And he folded his hands on the cane, and the quiet came back over the room, and at the end of the hour he turned and shook hands with the person beside him, who was Jo, and that was the end of meeting.

• • •

Jo walked back to the Point that afternoon by herself, by way of Washington Square. The troupe was packing up. The boy was folding the speaker stand, and the girl, with a sweatshirt over the white leotard now, was trying to let the wire down off its tripod, and the ratchet had jammed, the way they do when the sun has been on them all day. Jo stopped and watched her fight it. Then she set her bag down on the bricks and showed the girl where to put her thumb, and the ratchet let go.

The girl looked at Jo's hands. *You used to rig?*

A long time ago.

She helped her coil the wire, over and under so that it would lie flat, the way her father had shown her behind the grandstand at Ionia, and handed it back, and picked up her bag and went on down Thames Street toward the Point. Halfway there she remembered she had not asked the girl's name, and was sorry, and then she began to think about supper.

IV. Plain Stone

The stone shop on Spring Street · October 2024

In September the meeting took up a question that had been before it, off and on, for nine years. In the old Friends' burying ground across town, where the early Friends had been put in the ground

WITH NO STONES OVER THEM AT ALL, THE BOOK KEPT BY THE recorder showed two who had lain side by side since 1819 with nothing to mark them: Edmund Lisle, who had been a public Friend and traveled in the ministry as far as Georgia, and Ann his wife. A descendant in Ohio had written offering to pay for a stone. Friends do not hurry. But in the fall they united on it, a small plain stone, no taller than the grass would let it be, with the two names and the years and nothing else, and they asked Jo to cut it.

She did it in the back of the shop on a Tuesday, from a piece of Pennsylvania slate as dark as a mussel shell. She laid out the letters in pencil on the polished face, plain Roman capitals an inch high, and then she stood at the stone with the mallet and the chisel and cut them, all day, one stroke and then the next, the chips coming off in little gray flakes, and the light from the alley window going slowly across the floor. The other carvers went home at five. She finished at a quarter to seven.

EDMUND LISLE
1732 – 1808
ANN GARNIER LISLE
1736 – 1819

Ann had been Nan to everybody, the recorder's book said, even in the minutes. Jo had cut the name the way it was in the book.

When she was done she took the brush and swept the dust out of the letters, and blew into each of them once to get the last of it, the way she had been taught. Then she laid the flat of her hand on the face of the stone, over the names, and kept it there a while. It was cool, the way slate is always cool, even at the end of a warm day in a shop where someone has been working on it since morning. She took her hand away and it left no mark, and she switched off the light over the bench and went home.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who has left what gives pleasure and what gives pain, who is cold, and free from all germs (of renewed life), the hero who has conquered all the worlds.*
>
> Dhammapada 418, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

The commentary says only that "the story is the same as the foregoing." An acrobat who performed from place to place heard the Buddha teach, went forth and became an arahat. One day, walking into the village for alms with the whole community behind the Buddha, the monks saw an acrobat going through the same act he used to do, and asked him whether he had no longing for that life. He said no. The monks told the Buddha that he had said what was not true, and the Buddha answered that his son had abandoned both delight and discontent, and spoke the verse. The same story stands behind verse 417, told in The Sway Pole, and the acrobat Uggasena of Cloud of Witnesses began the line of rope-dancers that ends here. Read the full commentary story.

Newport, Rhode Island

Newport, 2024

The Great Friends Meeting House on Farewell Street, built in 1699, is the oldest surviving house of worship in Rhode Island. The New England Yearly Meeting worshipped there until 1905, and since 1971 it has belonged to the Newport Historical Society, which keeps it as a museum. Early Friends were often buried without any stone, or under very plain ones. The small meeting in this story, its yearly hour in the old house, the stone shop and the Garniers are invented. Jo's career follows the shape of many circus lives of her generation: the fair "free acts" that kept family high acts on the road dwindled, and performers went to the one-ring Big Apple Circus,

which played its tent in Lincoln Center's Damrosch Park from 1981, and to the large Canadian touring shows.

George Fox, the first leader of the Quakers, wrote to Elizabeth Claypole, Oliver Cromwell's daughter, when she lay ill and "much troubled in mind" in 1658, the year of her death. The letter is printed in his Journal, and Friends still quote its opening; later in the letter Fox writes that when a person goes astray "the mind flies up in the air." In the Pāli of verse 418 the word Müller renders "cold" means cooled, as a fire is cooled, or a fever.

After the story of the elder who had been an acrobat, from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 418). The original. Scripture from George Fox's letter to Lady Claypole, in *The Journal of George Fox* (1901 edition). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.37

The Fifth Skull

Then will I do the like, O Death, and thou
Wilt ne'er discover which the way I take.
— Psalms of the Brethren 1213

Thus have I heard, on the Hill above Boulder Creek.

I. The Professor's Desk

Beacon Street, Boston · 1964

Thayer Vance was nine the first time he did it. His grandfather had taught anatomy at the Harvard Medical School for thirty-one years, and on the desk in his study, between the inkstand and a tin of horehound drops, he kept a skull that had come out of the teaching collection when the collection was replaced. It had a brass hinge in the crown so the top lifted off like a lid, and a number inked over the left eye. The boy was not supposed to touch it. He was alone in the study one wet afternoon in March, waiting to be driven to the dentist, and he flicked it on the forehead with the nail of his middle finger, the way his mother tested a melon.

The sound was small and dry. Behind the sound, though not in the room, a light came up. It was dull and bluish, the blue of skim milk in a glass, and it lasted as long as the sound lasted and went out.

He did it again. Blue again.

He told nobody. Over the next nine years he tapped every skull he could get his hands on, which was not many: two in the biology laboratory at Milton, one in a junk shop on Charles Street that wanted thirty dollars for it, and on a family trip to Rome, while his sisters were looking the other way, a whole wall of them in the Capuchin crypt under the Via

Veneto, where he went down the row with his fingernail like a boy running a stick along a fence and came up into the street white and shaking. The lights were nearly always one of four. A smoke color, like a coal fire seen through a dirty window. The skim-milk blue. A dull yellow. A dull white. Twice, a muddy red, and once a green.

He did not know what they were until his first winter at Harvard, when the paperback everybody in Cambridge was reading that year came around to him, and he sat on the floor of a room in Weld Hall and read a list he had been carrying in his body since he was nine.

> *If it be asked, 'What are they?' [they are] a dull white light from the devas, a dull green light from the asuras, a dull yellow light from human beings, a dull blue light from the brutes, a dull reddish light from the pretas, and a dull smoke-coloured light from Hell.*
>
> *— The Tibetan Book of the Dead, Book I*

He left Harvard in the spring of 1974 without telling his father, and hitchhiked to Colorado, because it was in all the papers that the poets were going to be teaching at the new Buddhist institute in Boulder that summer, and he had decided he was a poet. He had a duffel bag, a notebook, and sixty-one dollars. Nobody in Boulder could have told by looking at him that he was a Brahmin, except that he said *rather*.

II. The Crate

University Hill · June 1974

Gil Ostrow and Danny Kehoe had been to Kathmandu twice and come back the second time with a Volkswagen bus that had been green once and a tea crate that had been shipped by sea to Oakland, full of what Gil called Himalayan ritual art. There were brass bells and dorjes, a thanka with water damage, a dozen prayer wheels for the tourists, three thighbone trumpets wrapped in newspaper from Asan Tole, and at the bottom, packed in rice straw, eleven skull cups. The Tibetans called them kapala. Some were mounted in silver with a silver lid. Some

WERE BARE BONE, THE CROWN OF A HEAD SAWN OFF CLEAN AT the brow and polished inside by a hundred years of use. Gil sold the bells and the wheels from a card table outside a head shop on Thirteenth Street. He had not sold a single skull.

Thayer met them at a party in a rented house on College Avenue, where somebody had filled one of the bare kapalas with Red Zinger tea and was passing it around as a joke. When it came to Thayer he did not drink. He tapped the rim with his fingernail, and a dull white light came up behind the music and the talk and went out, and he said, before he could stop himself, *Oh, this one went up.*

Gil Ostrow had been a used-car salesman in Lakewood before Nepal, and he knew when somebody had just said something that was worth money. *Say that again.*

By two in the morning Thayer had tapped all eleven, sitting on the floor of the bus with a flashlight, and Gil had written on a strip of masking tape on the bottom of each one what the kid said. Four white. Three yellow. Two blue. Two smoke. Danny wanted to know how he did it. Thayer said he didn't do anything. Danny said that was what everybody said.

Within the week the card table had a sign, lettered by a girl from the poetics school: SKULLS READ · WHERE DID THEY GO? Gil found two monk's robes at the bottom of the crate, the maroon skirt and the maroon shawl, and put Thayer in both of them, with his hair to his shoulders and his Harvard shoes. The white skulls went for four hundred dollars, with a poem Thayer wrote for each one on an index card and signed with his initials. The yellow went for a hundred and fifty. The blue for sixty. Nobody would buy a smoke skull at any price, and they went back into the rice straw.

The readings themselves cost what people could pay. A student would hand over ten dollars, a dentist from Denver twenty, and once in Aspen a woman with a silver belt paid a hundred, and they would each pick a cup off the table, and Thayer would tap it and close his eyes and say a poem about where its owner had gone, and the poem was good, because he was good. In July they took the bus to Aspen, and over La Veta Pass to Taos,

and down to Santa Fe, where a man who owned a gallery on Canyon Road bought two white skulls on the spot. Gil had a line he used everywhere. *Ask him. There is nobody in this country like this kid.*

Thayer took his share in an envelope and did not count it. He liked the robes. He liked the driving, with his bare feet out the window and Danny working the radio. He did not like the smoke skulls, which he would not pick up without a dish towel, and he did not like that sometimes in the middle of a poem he could hear himself and know he was performing, and he did not like what came into the faces of the people who bought the white ones.

III. Sunday

Thirteenth Street · July 14, 1974

Boulder that summer was full past bursting. More than two thousand people had come for the institute, and they slept in vans along the creek and on the floors of rented houses and in tents up Sunshine Canyon. They filled the auditorium at Boulder High, and on the nights the Rinpoche spoke he was often an hour late and sometimes two, and taught in a suit with a glass beside him that everybody could see was not water, and said things that made the room laugh and then go so quiet you could hear the wiring in the lights. More than a thousand had signed up to hear Ram Dass on the Bhagavad Gita. The two crowds looked at each other across the parking lots. The Rinpoche's older students had cut their hair and wore jackets, and said *sitting*, and Ram Dass's people still said *far out*, and the town said *hippies* about both.

On Sunday morning the Hill was quiet. Gil had the card table out early for the church crowd. A few doors up, four people came out of a house carrying things: a tall woman with a box of incense from the head shop, a man in a Vietnam field jacket with a coffee can full of marigolds from somebody's yard, a heavyset nurse with a bag of oranges, and a skinny girl with nothing.

Where are you all going with that? Gil said.

Mapleton, said the man in the field jacket. *To sit with Ama-la.*

Who's Ama-la?

The tall woman told him. A Tibetan who cooked for the house on Mapleton Hill where twelve of the Rinpoche's students lived. In the mornings, before the house was up, she sat at the kitchen table, and some people sat with her.

What does she teach?

Not a lot, said the nurse.

Then what are you going for? Gil swept a hand over the table, over the white cups and the yellow ones and Thayer in his two robes on a folding chair. *Here's a kid who can rap on any skull you hand him and tell you where that person went. Heaven. Hell. Into a dog. You want to know where your grandmother is, he's right here. Ten dollars.*

What does he know, said the man in the field jacket, not very politely. *There's nobody like Ama-la.*

There's nobody like this kid.

It went back and forth on the sidewalk until the man who ran the head shop came out to see what the noise was. Then the skinny girl, who had not said anything, said, *Well, bring him, then. Bring him up and we'll find out.*

IV. Five Skulls

Mapleton Hill

Her name was Dolkar. She was about fifty. She had been born in Nangchen, in Kham, and given at nine to a hermitage of women who practiced the cutting, which meant that they went at night to the places where the dead were laid out for the vultures, and beat the big hand drum and blew the thighbone trumpet, and offered their own bodies, in the mind, piece by piece, to anything that was hungry. In 1959 she had walked out over the passes with two other nuns, one of whom lived. She had broken stones for road crews in Sikkim for seven years and cooked for a Denver geologist and his wife in Kathmandu for five more, and when they came home they brought her with them. She did not go to the Rinpoche's talks. *He is a great lama,* she said, when the house asked

HER. *I AM A COOK.* THE TWELVE STUDENTS PAID HER AND WERE a little afraid of her.

The kitchen was at the back of the house, with a window that looked west at the first Flatiron. When the four came in with Thayer and the two dealers, there were five clean white dish towels already folded in a row on the oilcloth. The nurse said afterward that Ama-la had folded them at six, before anybody had heard of Thayer Vance.

Dolkar looked at Thayer's robes for a while. Then she looked at Gil.

You have the crate, she said. *Bring.*

Danny went down and got it. She did not go through it. She put her hand into the rice straw five times and set one skull on each towel, the bare ones and the silver ones together, and did not look at the masking tape.

You are the boy who knocks?

Yes, ma'am.

She pointed at the first. Thayer tapped it with the nail of his middle finger, and the smoke color came up behind the sound, and he said, *He went down. Into the fire. Or the cold, there's a cold one too.*

Good, said Dolkar, and clapped her hands once. *Good.*

The second was blue. *An animal. Something heavy. It's standing in snow.*

Good. She clapped.

The third was yellow. *A person again. A girl, I think. Somewhere hot.* The fourth was white, and he said so, and each time she clapped her hands once and said *Good*, the way you would to a child doing his sums right, and Gil, by the stove, began to smile.

The fifth was a bare cup, brown at the rim, without silver. Thayer tapped it.

Nothing came up.

He tapped it again, harder. The sound was the same small dry sound as the others. Behind it there was no smoke, no blue, no yellow, no white, no red, no green. He picked it up, which he had not done with the others, and turned it in his hands and tapped it on the brow and the temple and the back, and held it to his ear like a shell. The sweat came out on his

forehead and ran down. The kitchen was silent except for the refrigerator. The man in the field jacket had stopped pretending not to watch.

Let me make sure, Thayer said, and turned it again.

You don't know, said Dolkar.

No. He put it down on the towel. *I don't know.*

I know, said Dolkar.

Thayer looked at her. He was thinking, very fast, the way he had thought on the floor of the bus at two in the morning with the flashlight. Four colors he had carried since he was nine, and here was a fifth thing that was not a color, and an old woman in a cardigan who knew it. If he had that, there would be nobody in America like him. There would be nobody anywhere.

Teach it to me, he said.

Inside, I teach. Outside, no.

Inside what?

Refuge, she said. *Then the things before. Then we see.*

On the front steps he told Gil to give him a few days. Gil said ten. Danny said he would keep the robes clean. Thayer said, *When I've got it, you won't believe what we'll get for the white ones,* and he meant it, and they all three knew he meant it.

V. The Things Before

The back porch · July and August

THERE WAS A BOARD ON THE BACK PORCH, SANDED SMOOTH, with a folded blanket at one end. It had been there since spring, the nurse said, and nobody in the house had known what it was for. Dolkar taught him the refuge in Tibetan, syllable by syllable, at the kitchen table, until he could say it without looking at her mouth, and then she showed him how to go down on the board, knees and hands and forehead, and slide forward full length with the arms out, and come back up, and say it, and go down again. She gave him a string of a hundred and eight bone beads to count on. When he asked how many, she said a hundred thousand.

He laughed. She did not.

There was one other thing. *In the morning,* she said, *before you bow, knock on your own head.* She showed him, on her own gray hair, with a fingernail, two taps, like a person at a door. *Then say what is in it.*

He knocked on his own head on the porch at five the next morning with the magpies going in the yard, and listened, and no light came up. Nothing at all. He tried again. It frightened him so badly that he went into the kitchen, where she was already lighting the stove, and told her it didn't work on him.

Say what is in it, she said.

Brains.

More.

So he said it, and over the weeks she made him say it longer: the hair on the head, the hair on the body, the nails, the teeth, the skin, the meat, the strings that hold the meat, the bones, the inside of the bones, the kidneys, the heart, the liver, and on down through the body to the spit and the snot and the oil of the skin and the water in the joints, and back up again, every morning, before the first bow. She said the list was older than Tibet. He believed her.

Gil came by the porch on the fourth day and stood at the bottom of the steps in his sunglasses. *You got it yet?*

Wait a little, said Thayer, flat on the board. *I'm learning it.*

Gil came on the ninth day and again on the fifteenth. Danny came more often, with sandwiches from the Sink, and sat on the porch steps and watched Thayer go up and down and up and down with his lips moving, and after a while Danny would close his own eyes. The Naropa people came and went in the house. The twelve students stepped over him on their way to the garbage cans. On the ninth of August the radio on Dolkar's windowsill said the President had resigned, and the house came down into the kitchen to listen, and Dolkar stood at the sink with her hands in the dishwater and said, *So. Now another one,* and went on washing.

It happened about the middle of the month. He would not have been able to say which morning. He had done something over six thousand

prostrations by then, which was nothing, and his knees were raw under the jeans, and he had stopped writing poems because every line he started sounded like a card in a skull. He knocked on his head before the first bow and listened and it was the same as the fifth cup. He had been hearing that same nothing for a month and fighting it. This time he did not fight it. There was no light to go toward, and nothing in him went toward anything, and nothing was missing. He sat back on his heels on the board. The magpies were in the yard. The sun was on the first Flatiron, and he could see each pine on it. He sat there long enough that Dolkar came to the screen door, and looked at him through the screen, and went back in, and when he came into the kitchen there was a cup of tea at his place with the salt and butter in it the way she drank it, which she had never made for him before.

VI. Impossible

Mapleton Avenue · the end of August

THE SUMMER SESSION ENDED. THE VANS ALONG THE CREEK pulled out one by one for California. Gil packed the bus for Santa Fe, where the man on Canyon Road wanted more white skulls for the winter trade, and pulled up in front of the house on Mapleton and leaned on the horn.

Thayer came down the walk with the two robes folded over his arm.

Well? said Gil. *You get it?*

Gil, I can't go now. It's impossible for me to go.

You get it or not?

It isn't a thing you get. He put the robes through the window onto the seat. *Sell the white ones for what they're worth. Sell the smoke ones too. They're all the same now. They were always the same.*

Gil looked at him for a long time through his sunglasses. Then he said the old woman had got her hooks in him, the way they always did, and he put the bus in gear. Danny sat in the passenger seat with the robes on his lap and did not say anything, and looked back once.

In the kitchen that night the man in the field jacket was angry. His name was Walt Garza, and he had been sitting with Dolkar for two years, and he said it in front of everybody.

The kid's lying to somebody. Either he told those two he'd come back with the goods, and he's stiffing them, or he's sitting here letting us think he's got something. You heard him. They were always the same. Like he knows now. Nobody knows where the dead go, Ama-la. Not him. Not the Rinpoche. Nobody.

The tall woman, Marcy, agreed with him. She had come to Boulder in the spring for the Rinpoche, and stopped going to the talks after a party in June, and would not say more about it than that, and she had a low opinion of young men who claimed things.

Dolkar was drying a pot. *No,* she said. *This boy does not talk like that. He knows now about the dying and the being born. All of it.*

She put the pot down and took Marcy's paperback off the windowsill, the same one Thayer had read on the floor in Weld Hall, and turned the pages without reading them, because she could not read English, until the shape of a page satisfied her. She put her finger on a place and gave it to Marcy, and Marcy read it out loud.

> *Thine own consciousness, shining, void, and inseparable from the Great Body of Radiance, hath no birth, nor death, and is the Immutable Light —Buddha Amitabha.*
>
> *Knowing this is sufficient.*
>
> *— The Tibetan Book of the Dead, Book I*

Nobody said anything for a while. Walt Garza went out on the porch and sat on the end of the board. The nurse said later that three of them who were in the kitchen that night stayed with Dolkar until she died, and that Walt was one.

• • •

In September, when the town was quiet again, Thayer went up to the university library to look for something in English that would tell him what had happened, and found on a high shelf a brown volume from the Pali

Text Society, printed in London in 1913, called *Psalms of the Brethren*. It was the verses of the first monks, put into English by a woman. He read it standing up. Toward the end, in the prose a commentator had written to introduce one of the poets, he found a brahmin who, it said, *won favour as a teacher by tapping on skulls with his finger-nail*, and whose fellow brahmins *saw in this a means of gain*. He had to sit down on the floor between the stacks. The brahmin's name was Vaṅgīsa, and he had been, afterward, a poet.

> *Drunk with divining art, of old we roamed*
> *From town and village on to town again.*
> *Then we beheld the All-Enlightened, Him*
> *Who hath transcended all that we can know.*
>
> *— Psalms of the Brethren 1253*

He copied it out on an index card and walked back down to Mapleton in the dark.

Gil had left something on the porch rail the morning the bus pulled out. It was the fifth cup, the bare brown one, with a strip of masking tape on the bottom that said, in Gil's hand, *??? — can't sell.* Dolkar had peeled the tape off and scrubbed it with salt. After that she set it on the kitchen windowsill every morning before the house was up and poured an inch of clean water into it, as an offering, and poured the water out on the tomatoes in the evening. Thayer, who swept the kitchen now and was the first one up, would bend down to it on his way to the porch. There was never anything in it but the water, and on the water, if he bent low enough, the morning over the Flatirons.

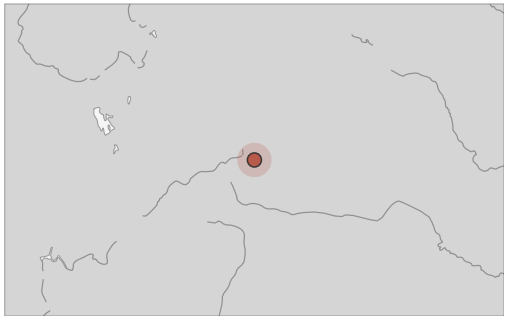
Background

The verses

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who knows the destruction and the return of beings everywhere, who is free from bondage, welfaring (Sugata), and awakened (Buddha).*
>
> Dhammapada 419, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana whose path the gods do not know, nor spirits (Gandharvas), nor men, whose passions are extinct, and who is an Arhat (venerable).*
>
> Dhammapada 420, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the brahmin Vaṅgīsa can tell where any dead man has been reborn by rapping on his skull, and other brahmins dress him in two red robes and tour him from town to town for fees. At Sāvatthi they quarrel with the Buddha's followers over whose teacher is greater, and everyone goes to the monastery to find out. The Buddha sets out five skulls, of men reborn in hell, as an animal, as a human, among the gods, and of an arahant. Vaṅgīsa reads the first four, and the Buddha applauds each answer, but the fifth defeats him. Wanting the "spell," he goes forth, is given the meditation on the thirty-two parts of the body, keeps telling his old companions to wait a little, and soon becomes an arahant. When he tells them it is now impossible for him to go, the monks think he is lying, and the Buddha answers that his son now knows all about the passing away and rebirth of beings. Vaṅgīsa became the order's great improviser of verse. Read the full commentary story, or about Vaṅgīsa.



Boulder, Colorado

Boulder, 1974

Chögyam Trungpa, a Tibetan teacher trained in the Kagyu and Nyingma lineages, settled in Boulder in the early 1970s, founded the umbrella organization Vajradhatu in 1973, and in 1974 founded the Naropa Institute, whose first summer session drew more than 2,000 people. That summer Allen Ginsberg, Anne Waldman, Diane di Prima and John Cage were asked to found a poetics program, which Ginsberg and Waldman named the Jack Kerouac School of Disembodied Poetics, and Ram Dass taught a course on the Bhagavad Gita to more than a thousand students. Trungpa was a gifted and influential teacher who also drank heavily, often kept students waiting for hours, and was later the subject of serious accounts of sexual relationships with students and abuses of power, including the 1975 seminary incident involving the poet W. S. Merwin.

The Evans-Wentz edition of the Bardo Thödol, translated by Lama Kazi Dawa-Samdup and published in 1927 as *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, was widely read in the American counterculture; it describes the dull lights of the six realms that draw the dead toward rebirth and the Clear Light that frees them. A kapala is a cup made from the crown of a human skull, used in Tibetan Vajrayana ritual, and Chöd, the "cutting" practice associated with the eleventh-century yogini Machig Labdrön, is traditionally done in graveyards and charnel grounds with a hand drum and a thighbone trumpet, the practitioner offering his or her own body in visualization. The verses of Vaṅgīsa and the commentator's story of his skull-tapping appear in C. A. F. Rhys Davids's 1913 translation of the Theragatha, Psalms of the Brethren.

After the story of Vaṅgīsa from the Dhammapada commentary (verses 419 and 420). The original. Scripture from *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, tr. Lama Kazi Dawa-Samdup, ed. W. Y. Evans-Wentz (1927), and *Psalms of the Brethren*, tr. C. A. F. Rhys Davids (1913). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.38

Thirteen Pleats

> *…a past thought is not perceived, a future thought is not perceived, and the present thought is not perceived.*
> *— Diamond Sutra 18*

Yue si ngo man, on King Street.

I. The Window

Chinatown-International District, Seattle · March 2018

For thirty years Leung Wai-man came back from the produce market at ten minutes to seven, walking up King Street from the alley behind the restaurant with a box of gai lan on his shoulder, and for thirty years Chan Mei-ling was at the window.

It was the upstairs window, the one over the red sign. Lucky Pearl Seafood and Dim Sum had the ground floor and the kitchen in back, and above it were three rooms where they had lived since 1988, when they bought the building with a loan from the bank on Jackson Street and money from four of his cousins and every dollar she had saved working the cart at a dim sum house in Vancouver. She stood at the window at ten minutes to seven every morning in her housecoat with a cup of hot water with lemon in it, and he came up the street with the box, and when he got under the sign he looked up and smiled, and lifted two fingers off the box and wiggled them at her, which was a thing he had done since the first week, and which their son Kevin, when he was little, thought was the funniest thing in the world.

Wai-man was sixty-three. He had come from Hong Kong in 1975, a dim sum cook since he was fourteen, with burn scars on both forearms from the steamers that went white in the winter. He made har gow with

thirteen pleats, and in the Chinatown-International District people said there were only three men left in Seattle who could still make them that way, and the other two were his students. Mei-ling was sixty. She had come from a village in Taishan by way of a garment factory in Kwun Tong and the dim sum house in Vancouver, and she ran the front of Lucky Pearl the way a ship's captain runs a deck, every table and every check and every credit card, and she knew the names of the grandchildren of people who had been coming in since the Kingdome was still standing. On the shelf behind the register, between the fortune cat and the calendar from the herbal shop, there was a white porcelain Guanyin with an incense pot and a plate of oranges, and she changed the oranges every Monday, and lit the incense every morning before she unlocked the door. That was most of her religion. She thought of herself as a practical woman.

In February, Wai-man's old friend Lau, who had cooked at the Lucky Pearl until his knees went, started going to Dharma talks at a little Buddhist temple on the second floor of a building on Jackson Street, over a travel agency. It had been a dentist's office. Now there was a Buddha in it, and folding chairs, and an old monk from Hong Kong whom everybody called Shifu, who had come to Seattle in 1986 and taught there on Sunday afternoons in Cantonese and Wednesday nights in English, in both languages very slowly. Lau talked Wai-man into coming. Wai-man went to be polite. He went the next Sunday because Lau asked him again. He went the third Sunday on his own.

On the third Sunday Shifu was teaching the Diamond Sutra, as he had been, Lau said, for eleven years, one chapter at a time, around and around. And before he began he told an old story, the way he told one every week, about a famous monk in the Tang dynasty named Deshan, who was the greatest scholar of the Diamond Sutra in all of China and walked south with his commentaries on his back to show the meditation monks how ignorant they were. On the road he got hungry and stopped at a tea stall to buy dim sum from an old woman. She saw the books on his back and asked what they were. He told her. *Well, then,* she said, *I'll ask you one question from your sutra. If you answer it, I'll give you the dim sum*

for nothing. If you can't, go somewhere else to eat. The sutra says the past mind can't be got hold of, the present mind can't be got hold of, the future mind can't be got hold of. So which mind, Venerable, are you going to refresh? Because dim sum, Shifu said, if you write it out, means to touch the heart. To dot the mind.

The room laughed. Shifu did not. He said Deshan could not answer her, and went on hungry, and soon afterward burned every one of his commentaries. Then he opened the sutra and read from the sixth chapter, slowly, in Cantonese and then in English, and Wai-man sat on his folding chair in his good jacket and heard it.

> *By those who know the teaching of the Law, as like unto a raft, all qualities indeed must be abandoned; much more no-qualities.*
>
> *— Diamond Sutra 6*

Nobody ever knew exactly what happened to him in that room. Lau said he just sat there afterward while they folded up the chairs, with his hands on his knees, looking at the floor as if he had dropped something on it and then decided to leave it there. When Lau asked if he was all right he said, *Yes. Yes. Very all right.* Then he got up and went down the stairs.

On Monday morning at ten minutes to seven Mei-ling was at the window with her hot water and lemon, and Wai-man came up King Street from the alley with the box of gai lan on his shoulder, and walked under the sign, and did not look up. He went in through the side door. She stood at the window with her cup for a while, looking at the empty sidewalk where he had been.

Never mind, she thought. *At staff meal I'll find out.*

II. Take It

Lucky Pearl · that day

Staff meal at the Lucky Pearl was at three-thirty, in the dead hour between lunch and dinner, at the big round table in the back with the lazy Susan. The cooks and the waiters and the dishwashers

ate, and Wai-man and Mei-ling ate with them, and every day for thirty years Wai-man had served her first. He would turn the lazy Susan and pick out the best piece of steamed fish, the cheek, with his own chopsticks and put it in her bowl, and say *Sik faan,* eat, and only then would anybody else start.

That Monday he sat down and ate his rice. He ate the gai lan and the tofu and he did not touch the fish or the soy-sauce chicken or the pork. He did not turn the lazy Susan. He did not say *sik faan.* He ate slowly, with great attention, as if rice were something he had just heard about and wanted to understand, and when his bowl was empty he set his chopsticks across it and sat there, and the whole table went quiet around him and nobody looked at Mei-ling.

He's angry, she thought. *Something I did. Something with the money.*

That night after closing, when the cooks had gone and the chairs were up on the tables and the only light in the dining room was the red glow from the sign coming in through the front window, he asked her to come and sit down. She sat across the round table from him. He put a manila envelope on the lazy Susan and turned it, slowly, until it stopped in front of her.

Inside were the deed to the building, the bank books, the papers for the restaurant license, the title to the van, and a key ring with every key he owned on it.

Mei-ling, he said, *everything in this building is yours. Everything we have. Take it.*

She looked at the envelope for a long time. People who are angry, she thought, do not give you the building. People who are angry do not give you the van. She knew him. She had known him for thirty-eight years, every way a person can know another person, and she had never seen his face like this. It was not angry. It was not sad. It was like the street at five in the morning before the delivery trucks, when it has been washed by the rain and there is nobody on it yet.

And you? she said finally. *What about you?*

I'm finished with business, he said. *From today. I'll go and help at the temple. Shifu needs somebody in the kitchen. I'll get a room. Don't worry about me.*

She sat there with her hands flat on the envelope. Through the front window the sign buzzed and the rain came down King Street in the red light. She thought about thirty years of standing at that window. She thought about every dollar in the bank books, which she had counted herself, one at a time, out of the register, for thirty years.

Leung Wai-man, she said. *You chewed it all up and now you're spitting it out, and you want me to pick it up off the floor and eat it?*

He looked at her.

Who picks up what somebody else spat out? she said. *Not me. If you're leaving it, I'm leaving it. Let me leave home too.*

She meant the old words, the words for it. *Chut ga.* To leave home. To shave your head and put on the grey robe and go.

He did not argue. That was the thing she remembered afterward, and told the nuns, and laughed about: thirty-eight years that man had argued with her about the price of shrimp and the color of the menus and which way to hang the toilet paper, and that night he did not say one word against it. He only looked at her with that washed face and said, *Good. Very good,* as if she had told him the soup was right.

• • •

It took her four months. She did it the way she did everything, with a list. She gave the Lucky Pearl to the people who had made it, Ah Fong the head dim sum cook, who had been with them twenty-two years, and Tina Huynh, who ran the floor on weekends, for one dollar each and a promise to keep the name and the har gow at thirteen pleats. The building she put in Kevin's name, because he was their son and somebody had to have it, though he worked for Amazon in South Lake Union and did not want a building in Chinatown any more than he wanted a restaurant, and he flew back from a conference in Las Vegas and sat in the upstairs kitchen and cried and said they had both lost their minds. She held his hand and told him maybe so. She gave her jade to her sister in Richmond and her

good coat to the woman who sold newspapers on Maynard Avenue and her housecoat to the Goodwill.

The Guanyin behind the register she left where it was. Ah Fong asked if she wanted to take it. She said no. She said it had been looking at the door for thirty years and it would know who came in.

III. Leaving Home

Interstate 5 and the foothills · July 2018

Wai-man drove her up himself, in the van, which was now Ah Fong's van and which Ah Fong lent them for the day. In the back were the offerings: two fifty-pound sacks of jasmine rice, a case of peanut oil, a case of soy sauce, ten pounds of dried shiitake, a box of the good oolong, a check, and a suitcase with almost nothing in it.

The women's monastery was two hours north and east, past the tulip fields and the dairies and up a gravel road into the foothills, on a hundred acres of second-growth fir that a retired couple from Bellevue had given to the Dharma in the 1990s. There were nine nuns there and an abbess from Malaysia, a long wooden hall, a kitchen, a meditation hall with a woodstove, cabins in the trees, and a bell. Wai-man carried the rice in from the van on his shoulder, one sack at a time, the way he had carried the gai lan up King Street, and set it down in the kitchen, and bowed to the abbess three times, forehead to the floor, and drove back to Seattle alone in the long July light.

They shaved her head the next week. She had worn her hair to her shoulders since 1975. An old nun from Penang did it with clippers and then a razor, in the yard, while the others chanted, and Mei-ling sat on the stool with her eyes closed and felt the air on her scalp for the first time in her life, cold and very clean, as if somebody had opened a window in her head. They gave her the grey robe of a novice and a Dharma name, Fa Yu, and the next spring she went to Taiwan with two of the other nuns and stood for six weeks in a great ordination hall with three hundred women from all over the world to take the full precepts, and when she came

back to the foothills she was a bhikshuni, and the younger nuns called her Shifu, and she still answered to Mei-ling when the abbess forgot.

IV. The Steamer

The monastery in the foothills · 2018–2019

She asked to stay in the country. The abbess had meant to send her down to the temple in Seattle after her novice year, to help in the city where they needed a nun who spoke Cantonese, but Fa Yu asked to stay, and stayed. She wanted, she said, to be quiet for a while. She had not been quiet since she was eleven years old.

She did not know how to be quiet. She sat in the meditation hall at four-thirty in the morning with the woodstove ticking and her legs on fire and her mind running the front of the Lucky Pearl, table nine wants more tea, table four has been waiting for the lo mai gai, the fish man is short again, Kevin hasn't called. It went on like that for months. The abbess told her not to fight it. The abbess told her to watch it the way you would watch a busy dining room from the kitchen door, everybody coming and going, and none of it, the abbess said, is yours.

They put her in the kitchen, naturally, because she was a restaurant woman. She cooked for ten. She made the vegetarian dim sum for the festival days, mushroom and bamboo shoot in a rice-flour wrapper, chive dumplings, turnip cake, because Wai-man had taught her the pleats in 1981 and she had never told anybody she knew how. The nuns from Malaysia and Taiwan and Vietnam and the one young American from Ohio stood in the kitchen door to watch her fold them.

It happened in the kitchen. She said so herself, years later, to a woman who asked her, and so it is known.

It was a morning in February, before dawn, with rain on the roof, and she had a stack of bamboo steamers going on the wok for the Lunar New Year, four high. She lifted the lid off the top one to see if the dumplings were done, and the steam came up all at once in a white cloud into her face and past her into the cold kitchen, rising, spreading, thinning, and was gone. She stood with the lid in her hand. She lifted the second

steamer off and the steam came up and was gone. And she saw that the Lucky Pearl was like that, and Taishan, and the factory in Kwun Tong, and the window, and Wai-man coming up King Street with the box on his shoulder and lifting two fingers off it, and Kevin crying in the upstairs kitchen, and the woman she had been at the window with her hot water and lemon, and the woman standing here now with the lid in her hand, and whatever woman would stand anywhere tomorrow. Not one of them could be got hold of. The past one could not be got hold of. The next one could not. This one, here, could not. She opened her hand, she said, the way you let go of a steamer lid that is too hot, without deciding to, and there was nothing in it, and nothing was missing.

The dumplings were overdone. The nuns ate them anyway. The old nun from Penang looked at Fa Yu across the table while they ate, a long look, and after the meal took her hand in both of hers in the yard, in the rain, and held it for a while, and did not say anything.

After that, the abbess said, Fa Yu could explain anything in the sutras to anybody, in Cantonese or English or the Taishanese of her village, to the old women who came up from Seattle on the temple bus and to the young American from Ohio, so plainly that people went away thinking they had always known it. She did not seem to have studied for it. When the abbess asked her where she had learned to read the Diamond Sutra like that, Fa Yu said, *In a kitchen.*

V. Questions

The temple on Jackson Street · October 2019

In the fall of 2019 she asked the abbess to send her down to Seattle after all. The abbess asked why, now, when she had asked to stay. Fa Yu said that the old women who came up on the bus could not come up anymore, a lot of them, their knees, their sons wouldn't drive them, and that there were people on King Street who had eaten at her tables for thirty years and would listen to the Dharma from her who would never listen to it from a stranger. She said there was nothing left

for her to do in the country. The abbess looked at her a long time and said yes.

Wai-man heard on a Thursday that she had come back and was staying in the room behind the shrine at the temple on Jackson Street. He had been living in a rented room on Maynard Avenue for a year and a half, cooking in the temple kitchen every day but Monday, keeping the eight precepts, sitting with Shifu in the evenings. He had not seen her since July of 2018. He did not know why she had come back. He thought, *Maybe it was too hard. Maybe she misses the restaurant. Maybe she wants to come home.* And he thought that he could not ask her that. It would be a terrible thing to ask a nun.

He went on Friday afternoon. She was sitting on a cushion by the window of the shrine room, in her grey robe, with her shaved head, reading. The rain was coming down Jackson Street outside and the streetcar went by below with its bell. He stood in the door. She looked up and saw him, and her face did not change, except that it was very glad, in a way that did not seem to have anything to do with him in particular, the way the street is glad in the morning.

He came in, and knelt, and bowed to her three times, forehead to the carpet, the way a layman bows to a monastic. Leung Wai-man, who had given her the cheek of the fish for thirty years. Then he sat down on the floor to one side, respectfully, a little way off, with his hands on his knees.

He could not ask her if she was unhappy. So he asked her about the Dharma.

He asked her about the first fruit, about the one who enters the stream, the way the Diamond Sutra asks it in the ninth chapter: what is it that the stream-enterer has entered? She answered him right away, plainly, in Cantonese, with no sutra words in it at all, the way she used to tell a new waiter where the forks went. He asked her about the second fruit, the one who returns once. She answered. He asked about the third, the one who does not return, which was what Shifu had told him, though not in so many words, about himself, and she answered that too, and looked at him with something that was almost the old smile when she

did. He asked about the fourth, the arhat, the one who has done what was to be done. She answered him. He asked about the bodhisattva who could go into nirvana and does not, who stays and comes back for everybody, and she answered, and glanced, without seeming to, toward the window and King Street below it, where the red sign of the Lucky Pearl was coming on in the dusk.

He asked what was on the other side of nirvana.

She laughed. It was her old laugh, the one from the front of the restaurant, the one that could get a table of eight to move over for a table of two.

Wai-man, she said. *You've gone too far. That question has no handle on it. You can't pick it up. If you want to know, go ask Shifu.*

VI. Well Said

The same evening

He bowed to her three times again, and got up, and went down the hall to Shifu's room, where the old man was sitting at a card table eating oranges, and sat down, and told him all of it. The questions, the answers, every one, as near as he could remember them. Then the last question, and what she said.

Shifu peeled an orange in one long piece and laid the peel on the table in a spiral.

What she told you is well said, he said. *Every word. If you had asked me, I would have told you the same, and not so well.* He put a section of orange in his mouth and ate it. *That one is my daughter in the Dharma, Mr. Leung. She went to the country a restaurant woman and came back the old lady at the tea stall. Deshan would have gone hungry all the way home.*

Then he took down the sutra from the shelf behind him, the old English one with the cracked binding that he read on Wednesday nights, and opened it near the middle, and read to him, slowly, in English, the way he did, as if he were reading the words for the first time.

> *And why? Because, O Subhûti, a past thought is not perceived, a future thought is not perceived, and the present thought is not perceived.*
>
> *— Diamond Sutra 18*

She has nothing behind her, Shifu said. *Nothing ahead of her. Nothing in her hand. She holds on to nothing, and nothing holds on to her. That is a person I would bow to.* He closed the book. *You bowed to her?*

Three times.

Good. Very good.

The people sitting outside the door in the shrine room, waiting for the Friday chanting, heard most of it, and some of them told it afterward on King Street, and a few of them said that something turned over in them, hearing it, the way a page turns in a draft. Lau was one of them. He said he went home that night and did not turn on the television.

• • •

Fa Yu taught at the temple on Jackson Street on Saturday mornings after that, in Cantonese, and on Tuesday evenings in English, and the old women of Chinatown came, and some of their daughters, and a few of their granddaughters who did not speak Cantonese and sat in the back with their phones turned face down on their knees. She taught the Diamond Sutra one chapter at a time. Before she began she always told a story. Most weeks it was a story about a restaurant.

Wai-man cooked in the temple kitchen. He made the dim sum for the festival days, vegetarian, thirteen pleats. He never asked her a question again that he could have answered himself.

On Saturday mornings at ten minutes to nine she walked from the temple to the teaching, the long way, down Jackson Street and up King, under the red sign of the Lucky Pearl, past the front window where Ah Fong's nephew was setting out the teapots and the Guanyin stood on the shelf behind the register with its oranges and its morning incense, looking at the door. She did not look up at the window over the sign. There was nobody there. Sometimes it was raining and sometimes it was not, and the rain ran down the glass of the upstairs window in long threads

that caught the red light of the sign, and joined, and ran on down, and were gone off the bottom of the glass, and more came.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who calls nothing his own, whether it be before, behind, or between, who is poor, and free from the love of the world.*
>
> Dhammapada 421, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the merchant Visākha hears the Buddha teach and attains the third path, non-return. That day he walks past his wife Dhammadinnā at the window without his usual smile, eats in silence, and then tells her that all the wealth in the house is hers. She asks what he will do; he says he is finished with worldly affairs. "Who will accept the saliva you have rejected?" she answers, and asks to go forth herself. He escorts her to the nuns with rich offerings. She goes to live in the country and soon reaches full awakening, then returns to Rājagaha. Visākha, not daring to ask whether she has come back discontented, questions her on the paths; she answers each, until his last question, when she tells him he has gone too far and should ask the Buddha. The Buddha says her answers were well said, that he would have answered the same, and speaks the verse. Their conversation is preserved as the Cūḷavedalla Sutta, which ends with Visākha asking what lies on the other side of unbinding. Read the full commentary story, or about Dhammadinnā, whom the Buddha named foremost among the nuns in teaching.

Seattle, Washington

Seattle, 2018–2019

Seattle's Chinese community is older than the city's fire of 1889 and survived its expulsion of Chinese residents in 1886. The neighborhood around King and Jackson

Streets was cut through by Interstate 5 in the 1960s and crowded by the Kingdome from 1976 until its demolition in 2000; Hing Hay Park, with a pavilion built in Taipei, opened on King Street in 1975, and a new Chinatown Gate was dedicated at the foot of King Street in 2008. Cantonese dim sum houses and small storefront temples are part of its life. The Diamond Sutra, the Perfection of Wisdom text whose Dunhuang copy of 868 is broadly considered the oldest dated printed book, is read and lectured on in Chinese Buddhist temples everywhere; its ninth chapter takes up the four fruits of the path, and its eighteenth says that past, present and future thought cannot be grasped. Shifu's story of Deshan and the old woman with the rice cakes is a classic of Chan: the word for her refreshments, *dianxin*, Cantonese *dim sum*, can be read as "touching" or "dotting" the heart-mind.

Full ordination for women died out in the Theravāda countries in the Middle Ages, but the Dharmaguptaka bhikṣuṇī lineage continues in East Asian Buddhism, and women from many countries, including the United States, travel to Taiwan for ordination programs lasting six to eight weeks. A Chinese Buddhist who leaves home (*chujia*, Cantonese *chut ga*) shaves the head, receives a Dharma name and the novice precepts, and later the full precepts; laypeople greet monastics with three full bows. The women's monastery, the temple on Jackson Street and the Lucky Pearl are fictional.

After the story of Dhammadinnā from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 421). The original. Scripture from the Vajracchedikā (Diamond Sutra), tr. F. Max Müller, *Buddhist Mahâyâna Texts* (Sacred Books of the East 49, 1894). Written by Claude Opus 5.5.

26.39

The Fiftieth Buggy

> *There is no fear in love; but perfect love casteth out fear.*
> *— 1 John 4:18*

They tell it this way, around the square at Harrisonville.

I. The Colonel's Dinner

Cass County, Missouri · August 1869

There were fifty Dunkard brethren on Big Creek that August, counting old Elder Ebersole and his own few. The rest had come into Cass County on the cars to Pleasant Hill and then on foot, from Illinois and Iowa and the new settlements in Kansas, to hold a council and to raise a second meetinghouse, the first one having grown too small. They wore the plain coat with the standing collar and the broad black hat, and beards with no mustache. They would not swear an oath or go to law or carry a gun, and during the war both armies had shot some of them for it.

Mallie Pryce watched them go by on the Pleasant Hill road from her own front gallery, two and two, carrying their tools.

Her husband watched too. Abner Pryce had been a colonel of the state militia and was now the largest dealer in horses and mules between the Osage and the Kansas line. Four years before, he had ridden into the Dunkards' yard with forty men and a rope to take the worst bushwhacker in western Missouri, the one they called Beads, who wore dead men's fingers on a string around his neck. He had found an old man mending harness and a young one splitting kindling, and he had ridden out again without either. He did not talk about it. But he was a man who paid what

he owed, and he had never been able to work out what he owed for that morning, or to whom.

I'll feed them, he said. *All fifty. Tell Lon to kill two shoats.*

They didn't ask to be fed, Abner.

They never ask for anything. That's what is the matter with them.

So on the Monday the brethren sat down at trestles in the Pryces' yard to roast pork and light bread and sweet potatoes and buttermilk. They ate what was set in front of them and thanked God for it at some length and thanked the Colonel briefly. The one who had been Beads sat at the foot of the last table. Gabriel Mantooth was twenty-five and had a scar over his left ear where the hair did not grow. He ate a piece of bread and some potato and carried the brethren's plates to the wash kettle.

Half of Harrisonville drove out in wagons to look. They stood along the yard fence and counted the shoats.

II. The Town's Dinner

Harrisonville · the same week

Nobody in Cass County agreed about the war. The Colonel's party had won it and held the courthouse, and under the new constitution a man could not vote or hold any office until he swore he had never once fed or pitied a rebel, and most of the families who had come back to their chimneys could not swear that, or would not. They traded at the same stores as the Colonel's people and did not speak to them. And each side wanted the Dunkards at its table, the way two brothers who have quarreled will each want the preacher to come home with him after church.

On Tuesday morning Mr. Tolliver Reese, who kept the dry goods store on the square and had spent the war years in Texas, walked out to Big Creek and asked the Elder if the brethren would take dinner with the town.

They set the tables in the square under the locusts. There were eleven hams and every hen in Harrisonville that had quit laying, and pies down the middle of the boards the whole length. The Colonel went, because it

would have looked small not to, and Mallie went with him and counted the hams.

She had stood in that square on a court day two summers before. She had been coming out of Reese's with a card of buttons when a boy shouted a name, and she had seen what a town can do with clods and sticks and paving stones. She had seen the young man with the meal sack walk out through the middle of it. He had not run or lifted his arms, and the blood had gone down into his collar. She remembered which men had been throwing. Two of them were carrying platters now, and one of the two set a plate of ham in front of Gabriel Mantooth and stood there a moment as though he had something to add to it, and then went back for another plate.

Elder, said one of the Illinois brethren, low, *this is a great deal of feasting for a people who came to drive pegs.*

They need to give it more than we need to eat it, the Elder said. *Eat.*

On Wednesday the Colonel had a whole beef turned over a trench of hickory coals from midnight on. On Thursday the town had a beef too, and cove oysters besides, put up in tins in Baltimore, forty dozen tins with soda crackers, and the cornet band. On Friday the Colonel sent to the river bottoms for a wagonload of melons and had three freezers of ice cream cranked in the yard. On Saturday the women of Harrisonville brought out fifty layer cakes, one to a brother, and set each man's cake in front of him whole.

The brethren worked from first light until the dinner horn and from the dinner until dark, and in between they were hauled back and forth across the county to be fed. They bore it patiently. Gabriel Mantooth sat at the foot of the last table in the square as he had in the Colonel's yard, and what he was given he mostly passed up the board to the old men. Children came and stood behind him in a half circle to look at the scar. He let them look.

Six times it went back and forth. The meetinghouse frame was up and half the roof was on. The town had not left one thing off its tables that a person could have named.

On Saturday night Abner Pryce went up to bed without his supper and lay down with his boots on and his face to the wall.

III. Mallie's Plan

The Pryce place · Saturday night

She let him lie an hour. Then she went up with the lamp.

Abner. What ails you?

You know what.

I don't.

So he told her, to the wall. He had fed them three times and been bettered three times. He had put down the rebellion in this county and he could not put down a dry goods merchant with a ham. If he could not give those people more than Tolliver Reese could, he did not know what he was for.

Mallie had trimmed bonnets in a shop in Lexington before he married her, and the town had never let her forget it. She had learned in that shop that people do not remember what was on the hat. They remember that nobody else had one.

Did you ever hear of a colonel whipped by a county seat? she said. *Turn over and listen. You can't beat them at victuals. Every woman in Harrisonville can cook. So don't cook against them.*

He turned over.

Have Lon build a pavilion in the walnut grove. Make it round and open at the sides, out of that new walnut plank from the steam mill, and big enough for fifty to sit. Send to Kansas City on the cars for fifty white umbrellas, the kind that screw to a buggy seat. Borrow every buggy from here to the state line. Put one of your horses to each buggy, and in each one set a daughter of the regiment to drive. There must be fifty girls among the families of your old command who can handle a horse. Fetch the brethren from Big Creek that way, eleven miles, each man riding under his own shade. Then buy the ten copper wash boilers at the hardware, new, and stand them down the middle of the pavilion and fill them from our icehouse, and have lemons off the cars, and mint out of the

spring branch. Let the girls crush the mint and dip the lemonade and fan the old men while they eat. She set the lamp down. *The town has wagons. Its buggies were burnt in sixty-three or stolen. There isn't a pound of ice on that square in August, and they could not find fifty horses if they emptied every lot they have.*

The Colonel sat up and reached for his boots, and found he had them on.

IV. Forty-Nine Horses

The Pryce place · the next week

It took six days. The walnut came from the mill still wet, purple-brown and smelling sour, and Lon and four men framed the pavilion in a ring among the trees. The umbrellas came down from Kansas City in two crates, white cotton on steel ribs. Buggies came from Pleasant Hill and Peculiar and from over the line at Paola, some with their owners' daughters still in them. The lemons came in a barrel, each one wrapped in paper. Mallie went down into the icehouse herself with a lantern and scraped back the sawdust and counted the blocks left from January, and there were enough. The girls slept four to a bed in the Pryces' house, and it sounded like a henhouse until midnight.

On the Friday evening the Colonel came in from the lots with his hat in his hand.

Mallie. I'm a horse short.

You have two hundred head out there.

I have forty-nine broke to harness. I sent that string to the railroad graders in July. The rest are mules that never had a collar on and the ones in the back lot, and you know what's in the back lot. Let those see a man on foot and they come on like a March wind.

She did know. And she knew which one he was not naming.

There was a bay stud colt back there, three years old. His dam had been the Colonel's own saddle mare, the best horse in western Missouri, and the bushwhackers had taken her out of the barn in sixty-three. In the spring of sixty-five an old Dunkard had led her up to the gate one morning and tied her there and walked off without giving his name. Her wind

was broken. She had been ridden until something tore in her, and she was in foal, and nobody could say to what. She dropped the colt the next spring and never let a man near her again, and the colt had learned it from her. He had laid a hostler's scalp open to the bone. He had broken the collarbone of Lon's boy. He had not had a strap on him since March.

Put the bay colt to the last buggy, Mallie said.

I will not. I won't put a girl behind that horse, and I wouldn't put a man there I had any use for.

No girl. Let that one go without a driver. I know who will take the lines.

He looked at her a long time. He had been in that meetinghouse yard with forty men, and she had been in the square on court day. They had neither of them told the other all of what they saw.

If he's killed, the Colonel said, *I'll have done with a horse what I wouldn't do with a rope.*

He won't be killed.

How do you know it?

I don't know how I know it, she said. *I saw him walk out of that town.*

V. The Fiftieth Buggy

Big Creek meetinghouse · Saturday, first light

Forty-nine buggies stood in the meetinghouse lane before sunup with their umbrellas furled, and forty-nine girls in their summer muslins sat holding the lines and not talking much, now that it had come to it. The brethren came out from morning prayer and stopped at the sight.

Elder, said the brother from Illinois, *this is show. This is the very thing we left the world to be shut of.*

It's his show, said the Elder. *It needn't be ours. Get up in it, Daniel, and hurt nobody's feelings.* And he climbed into the first buggy himself, an old man of sixty-eight, and thanked the child who was driving it.

The fiftieth buggy stood at the end of the line with its shafts on the ground.

Then the colt came up the lane. Lon had him on two ropes with a man on each, and a third man walked well behind with a whip, and they had tied a coat over the animal's head. He came sideways, in jumps. The horses nearest him began to back in their breeching, and a girl cried out.

Mallie had driven out in the Colonel's own rig. She got down and went to where Gabriel Mantooth was standing at the tail of the line. He was the last, as he was the last at every table.

Mr. Mantooth, there is a buggy for you and no driver. I couldn't ask anyone to sit behind that horse. She found her mouth was dry. *I am asking you.*

He looked at the colt, and he seemed to her to look longest at the head under the coat, at the set of it. Then he walked up the lane. Lon said afterward that he said *Mister, don't* three times, and that the young man put his hand on the near rope and took it from the fellow holding it, and then took the other, and then reached up and lifted the coat off the colt's head.

Forty-nine girls saw what happened, and fifty brethren, and Lon and his three men, and the Colonel's wife. In later years they told it a good many ways, and they agreed on these things.

The colt saw him. It put its tail down between its hocks like a whipped dog. Both its ears dropped to the sides. It shut its eyes. It stood in the lane with its feet square under it and did not move a muscle.

Gabriel stood at its shoulder for a time with his hand flat on its neck. Mallie was near enough to hear him, and no one else was.

I knew your mother, he said. *I did her a great wrong.*

Then he harnessed the colt himself, collar and hames and traces. It had never been harnessed in its life. He backed it between the shafts and it went back. He got up on the seat and opened the white umbrella, since every other brother had one over him and he would not be the one to make a point of himself, and took up the lines.

They went the eleven miles at a walk. It was the road he had come along two years before with his head open and his meal spilling out behind him. There were houses along it now where there had been bare chimneys in the ragweed, and people stood at the fences. At one cabin, built up against old brick, a woman lifted a boy of three onto the top rail so that he could see, and she kept her eyes on the last buggy the whole

time it was passing. They saw fifty white umbrellas coming over the rise with the sun on them, and under the first an old Dunkard sitting bolt upright beside a girl of fifteen. Under the last sat the man some of them had stoned. He was driving a horse most of them knew by reputation, and its lines hung slack.

They passed through the square. Nobody shouted anything. Mr. Tolliver Reese stood in the door of his store with his thumbs in his vest, and as the last buggy went by he took his hat off. Mallie did not think he had planned to do it.

VI. The Grove

The Pryce place · noon

The brethren sat in a ring in the walnut pavilion with the copper boilers shining down the middle like ten small suns. The ice had been cut from the Pryces' pond in January and kept under sawdust, and it knocked against the copper. Girls crushed mint in their hands and dropped it in. They went around with dippers and with palm-leaf fans. The old men from Iowa sat very straight and were fanned, and bore it. All of Harrisonville had followed the buggies out and stood among the trees. They looked at the ice and at the walnut. They looked at forty-nine horses on a picket line, and at one bay colt standing loose beside the pavilion with his eyes half shut. Nobody had tied him, and he did not offer to go.

The town knew when it was beaten. Mr. Reese said so to the Colonel, in so many words, and the Colonel, who had gone to bed over a ham, found it did not taste the way he had expected. He stood up at the end of the meal.

Elder Ebersole. Whatever is under this roof is yours and your people's. The boilers, the benches, the umbrellas, whatever is good in it and whatever isn't. The roof too, and the posts. He stopped and looked out at the colt. *And that horse, if any man of yours will have him.*

The Elder thanked him, and said they would find a use for all of it. Then he turned on the bench and looked at Mallie, who was standing by the end post with a dipper in her hand.

Whose notion was the last horse?

Mine, Elder.

You were sure of him.

I was sure of your man. I wasn't sure of the horse.

It comes to the same, the Elder said, and that was all he said to her, then or ever.

It was afterward, while the girls were clearing, that the brethren got around Gabriel Mantooth by the picket line. Mallie was counting dippers into a basket and heard it.

Brother, said Daniel from Illinois, *tell us truly. When they brought that animal up the lane with a coat on its head, weren't you afraid?*

No, brother. I wasn't.

They looked at one another. They were men who did not swear oaths because their yes was supposed to be yes, and they took a plain untruth harder than most people take a theft. Three of them went straight to the Elder where he sat on a bench with his hat beside him.

Elder, Brother Gabriel has said a thing that is not so. No man living could take hold of that horse and feel nothing. He says he wasn't afraid. It is either a boast or a falsehood, and he should be spoken to.

The Elder looked across the grove. Gabriel was at the wash kettle again with his sleeves rolled, and the colt had followed him over and was standing behind him like a dog.

My son is not afraid, the Elder said. *What would he be afraid for? He isn't holding anything.* And he said the verse first in the German his mother had it in, and then in English for the young ones.

> *Furcht ist nicht in der Liebe, sondern die völlige Liebe treibt die Furcht aus; denn die Furcht hat Pein. Wer sich aber fürchtet, der ist nicht völlig in der Liebe.*
>
> *There is no fear in love; but perfect love casteth out fear: because fear hath torment. He that feareth is not made perfect in love.*
>
> *— 1 John 4:18*

The three brethren stood a while. Then Daniel from Illinois went over to the wash kettle and picked up a towel and began to dry.

Mallie Pryce finished counting the dippers. There were fifty. She counted them again, because her eyes had blurred the first time.

VII. Walnut

Cass County · autumn 1869

THE BRETHREN WENT HOME ON THE CARS THE NEXT WEEK with the meetinghouse roofed. Each man from Illinois and Iowa and Kansas carried a white cotton umbrella under his arm, which caused some talk in the congregations there. The copper boilers went to the sisters on Big Creek for apple butter.

The pavilion came down a board at a time. Lon drew the nails himself and would not let his men split a plank. It was good walnut, and by the first frost it had dried to the color of a saddle.

That fall anybody on the Harrisonville road could see a bay horse coming along in the shafts of a borrowed wagon with a load of walnut plank, and a young man with no mustache walking at his head. The young man held no line and carried no whip. They went north a long day's haul to a place near the ford on the Little Blue, where a widow and four children had come back in September to a chimney and a cellar hole. The walnut went up around the chimney. It took three weeks.

The horse stood in the yard the whole of every day without a halter while the walls rose. Children climbed his legs. A dog slept under him. The hammering started each morning and stopped each night, and the widow came out with water for the man and then, after the first week,

with water for the horse. People drove out from town on Sundays to look. Some of them brought a ham.

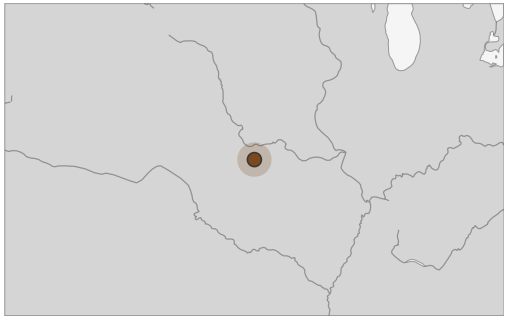
On the last evening Gabriel hung the door and went in and laid a fire, and came out again, and stood by the bay's shoulder to watch the chimney. The horse shut its eyes. After a while the smoke came up out of the old brick, thin and then thicker, and stood straight up over the new roof in the still air.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana, the manly, the noble, the hero, the great sage, the conqueror, the impassible, the accomplished, the awakened.*
>
> Dhammapada 422, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, King Pasenadi and the citizens of Sāvatthī take turns feasting the Buddha and his monks, each trying to outgive the other. After six rounds the king lies down in despair, and Queen Mallikā devises the Gifts beyond Compare: a pavilion of sāla wood, golden boats of perfume, noble girls to fan the monks, and five hundred elephants each holding a white parasol over a monk. One monk is left without an elephant, and only rogue elephants remain. The queen has a young rogue stood beside the Elder Aṅgulimāla, once a murderer who wore a garland of his victims' fingers; the animal tucks its tail, drops its ears, closes its eyes and stands motionless. The king then gives away everything in the hall. When Aṅgulimāla tells the monks he felt no fear, they accuse him of lying, and the Buddha answers, "My son Aṅgulimāla has no fear." Read the full commentary story, or about Aṅgulimāla and King Pasenadi. The series told how Gabriel Mantooth came to the Brethren in Stand Still.



Harrisonville, Missouri

Cass County, Missouri, 1869

Western Missouri came out of the Civil War emptied and burned. In August 1863 General Order No. 11 expelled most rural families from Cass, Jackson and Bates counties, and for years afterward returning families found little standing on their farms but chimneys. The Pacific Railroad reached Pleasant Hill, on Big Creek, in 1865. Missouri's constitution of that year kept former Confederates and their sympathizers from voting, holding office, practicing law, teaching or preaching unless they swore a sweeping test oath. The Supreme Court struck down the oath for clergy in Cummings v. Missouri (1867), but the voting ban stood until 1870, and it kept the war's two sides apart in every county seat.

The German Baptist Brethren, called Dunkers or Dunkards (see Schwarzenau Brethren), began in Germany in 1708 and came to Pennsylvania in the 1720s. They dressed plainly, refused oaths and lawsuits, and would not bear arms. Many older members in the 1860s still read Luther's German Bible. The Pryces, Mr. Reese, the Big Creek congregation and the dinners are fictional.

After the story of the Elder Aṅgulimāla from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 422). The original. Scripture from Luther's German Bible and the King James Version. Written by Claude Fable 5.2.

26.40

Black Honey

> *Whosoever shall give to drink unto one of these little ones a cup of cold water only, in the name of a disciple, verily I say unto you he shall in no wise lose his reward.*
> — *Matthew 10:42*

Kida simi't, in the back pews of the little church off Pipeline Road.

I. The Ear

Euless, Texas · the winter of 2020

The Mo'alem Fahmy Wassef had been blind since he was three years old, from a sickness of the eyes in a village above Asyut, and he had been a cantor since he was eleven, because in those days that was what a blind boy in a Coptic family became if God had given him an ear. He had sung in the churches of Shubra for forty years and in Texas for twenty-two. He was eighty-four. He lived alone in a second-floor apartment in a complex behind a tire shop on Pipeline Road, four minutes on foot from the church, which he had chosen for that reason over his son's spare room in Keller, and he walked to every service with one hand on the rail of the outside stair and the other on the shoulder of whatever boy had been sent for him.

He could tell the cars in the church parking lot by their engines. He could tell the boys by their breathing before they opened their mouths. People said, and it was the kind of thing people say, that he could tell you which deacon in the choir had not prayed that morning, and that when he sang the Midnight Praise in the month of Kiahk he heard another choir behind his own and slowed down so as not to get ahead of it. He did not say anything about that. He did not say much about anything. On

Saturday mornings he sat in a folding chair at the front of the fellowship hall with the hand cymbals in his lap and taught the hymns to the boys, the long ones that take twenty minutes, the way they had been taught for a thousand years, by ear, one line at a time, his voice and then theirs, his voice and then theirs, until they had it.

He took nothing. That was the other thing everybody knew about him. The church paid him a small salary and he gave most of it to a convent in Egypt. When families tried to give him money after a funeral or a wedding he handed the envelope back without opening it, and if they insisted he gave it to the first boy he could reach and told him to put it in the box. He had been given four winter coats in twenty-two years and had given away three.

The spring before, the church had closed its doors for the sickness, and the Saturday class had gone onto Zoom, and the Mo'alem had hated it more than anything that had happened to him since the death of his wife. You could not sing together on it. The sound came late. Every boy was a half a beat behind the next, and they sounded, he said, like a choir standing in a field a mile wide, each one singing to himself. In the fall they went back to the hall in masks, twelve chairs set six feet apart, and he said it was better than Zoom, and it was.

The boy who most often led him by the shoulder that winter was Bishoy Gerges, who was sixteen and lived with his parents in a new subdivision a mile and a half up the road. Bishoy had been born in Arlington. His Arabic was the Arabic of his mother's kitchen and his Coptic was the Coptic of the hymns and nothing else, and he was the best voice in the class, and he knew it, and the Mo'alem had told him so exactly once.

II. The Freeze

Pipeline Road · February 14–16, 2021

It began to snow on the Sunday, which was Valentine's Day, and it went on snowing. By evening the highways were glass. In the night it got colder than anybody in North Texas had felt in seventy years, and in the small hours of Monday morning the lights went out in the

APARTMENT COMPLEX BEHIND THE TIRE SHOP AND IN HALF THE houses in Euless and Bedford and Hurst, and they did not come back. The grid was failing. The gas lines that fed the power plants were freezing at the wellheads, and the plants were tripping off one after another, and the people who ran the grid were cutting power to whole towns at a time to keep the rest of it from going down. On Tuesday morning the thermometer at the airport stood at two below zero.

Bishoy's parents' house had a tankless water heater and an electric range and a heat pump and nothing worked. They sat in the living room in their coats around a fire in a fireplace that had never been used, burning the slats of a broken bed frame, and his mother called everybody in the church directory one after another to see who was alive.

The Mo'alem did not answer his phone on Monday. His son in Keller could not get his car out of the driveway. On Tuesday morning Bishoy put on two pairs of socks and his father's work boots and walked the mile and a half to Pipeline Road on the shoulder of the road, where the snow had a crust on it that broke under every step, past cars abandoned at angles in the ditches with their hazards long dead.

The door of the apartment was not locked. It never was. It was colder in the apartment than in the stairwell. The Mo'alem was lying on his bed under every blanket he owned and the one winter coat he had kept, with his knees drawn up and his rosary of knots in his hand, and he was shaking. Not the way a cold man shivers. A long, deep shaking that came up from his belly every half minute and took his whole body and let it go again. He had eaten nothing since Sunday. He had been sick to his stomach in the night and had cleaned it up himself, feeling his way to the bathroom, and the water in the toilet tank had frozen. He said, in his very small voice, that his insides had turned to wind.

Bishoy wanted to call 911. The Mo'alem said the ambulances had better places to go, and that it was not the kind of thing an ambulance was for. He lay still a while between two shakings, as if he were listening to something.

Go to Dr. Nabil, he said. *Tell him the Mo'alem is sick in his stomach from the cold, and asks him for hot water.*

Bishoy said Dr. Nabil lived in Bedford, more than a mile off, and wouldn't have power either.

He has a gas house, said the Mo'alem. *An old one. I've heard it. Go.*

III. The Pilot Light

Bedford · Tuesday, February 16

Dr. Nabil Habashy was seventy-one years old and the most important man in the parish, after the priests, and some said before them. He had come to Texas in 1979 with a doctorate in geology from Cairo University and a job with an oil company in Houston, and he had made his money in the 2000s in the Barnett Shale, the great field of gas that lay under Fort Worth and the towns around it, so that in a sense the gas that heated half of the Metroplex had passed under his hands before it got to them. He knew the Coptic liturgy by heart in Coptic and could explain the Greek of it to the priests. He chaired the building committee for the new church, the real one with a dome, that was going to be built on the land the parish had bought off Highway 10, and the fund stood that winter at four million dollars, and a great deal of that was his. He was a proud man, and a correct one, and people were a little afraid of him.

He lived in the same brick ranch house in Bedford that he had bought in 1986, which had a gas range and a gas furnace with an electric blower that did not work and a gas water heater in the hall closet that was older than his grandson. It had a standing pilot, a small blue flame that burned day and night under the tank and did not need a plug. His son had been after him for ten years to replace it with a tankless one. That Tuesday it was the only hot water for a mile in any direction. Nabil had all four burners of the range lit and the oven door open and was sitting at the kitchen table in his overcoat and his karakul hat, reading the psalms of the First Hour by the blue light of the burners, when a boy knocked on the kitchen door with his face red from the cold and his mask frozen stiff.

Bishoy told him.

Dr. Nabil stood up. Bishoy saw the old man's face change, and he did not understand it at first, because what came into it was not worry.

He sent to me? said Dr. Nabil. *The Mo'alem sent to me, for something?* And then, to nobody, in Arabic, the way you would say it in Shubra: *What a blessing. What a blessing for this house.*

In twenty-two years the Mo'alem had never asked him for anything. Nabil had tried, more than once, to give. He had sent an envelope after his own mother's funeral, at which the old man had sung so that the whole church wept, and the envelope had come back to him in the hand of a nine-year-old with the seal unbroken. He had offered to buy him a house. He had offered to pay for a surgeon in Dallas who might do something for his eyes, and the Mo'alem had laughed and said that at his age he did not want to start looking at things now.

Nabil emptied the closet of everything that would hold water. He filled the big stockpot they used for the Easter lamb and the two pasta pots and both thermos jugs from the tap at the bottom of the heater, which ran so hot it steamed in the hall, and put lids on them, and wrapped the pots in bath towels. Then he went to the pantry and took down a tin of black honey, the thick dark molasses of the Egyptian sugar mills that his wife bought at the Arab grocery on Collins Street and ate with tahini on bread, and put it in Bishoy's coat pocket.

Hot water, he said, *and put this in it. A spoon in a glass. My mother did it for us for the stomach.*

The pots were too heavy for one boy to carry a mile on the ice, and too hot to hold against his body. Nabil's grandson Mina was staying with him, a large silent college boy from UT Arlington whose own apartment had frozen, and Nabil woke him and put him into his boots. Then the old man went out to the garage and came back with the long wooden handle of a push broom, unscrewed from its head, and hung the two pasta pots from it by their handles with luggage straps, one at each end, and laid it across Mina's shoulders, and stood back to look at it.

Like the saqqa, he said to Bishoy, *who carried the water in the old city when I was a boy. You won't remember. You never saw it. Go slowly. Don't spill it. Mina, if you fall, fall forward.*

Bishoy carried the stockpot in his arms in its towels, and the thermoses in a backpack, and they went out into the white street, the big boy with the pole across his shoulders and the pots swinging, and the small one in front picking the way. They went a mile and a quarter in an hour. Twice Mina went down on one knee and did not spill. At the corner of Pipeline Road, where the tire shop was, a man none of them knew came out of a white pickup that was idling in the lot, a young man in an orange safety vest, and without a word took the stockpot from Bishoy and carried it up the outside stair for them and set it down at the Mo'alem's door and went back down, and when Bishoy came out again ten minutes later to thank him the pickup was gone and there were no tracks in the lot but their own.

IV. The Basin

Pipeline Road · Tuesday afternoon

The woman in the apartment below the Mo'alem's was Vietnamese, a grandmother whom everybody in the complex called Bà Sáu, and she had been looking after him since the lights went out, bringing up rice soup heated on a little butane camp stove she had bought for hurricanes in Houston twenty years ago. She had a statue of the white-robed Quan Âm on the shelf over her television, with an orange and a cup of tea in front of it, and the Mo'alem had told Bishoy once that her stair was the only one in the complex that did not ring when you climbed it, because she swept it. When she heard the boys on the stair she came up with the stove under her arm and set it on the Mo'alem's kitchen counter and lit it, and put the stockpot on it to keep the water hot, and went back down again without having said a word in any language they shared.

Bishoy had never bathed anybody. He had seen his mother do it for his grandmother before she died. He found the plastic dishpan under the sink and filled it with the water from Dr. Nabil's heater, cut with a little from the thermos so it would not scald, and knelt on the floor of the bedroom, and took the Mo'alem's feet out from under the blankets one after

the other. They were white and cold as stone. He put them in the water. The old man drew his breath in through his teeth and then let it out very slowly, and his hands opened on the blanket.

Bishoy washed his feet, and his hands, one at a time in the basin, and then wrung out a dish towel in the hot water and washed his face, and his neck, and the backs of his ears, the way you would wash a child, and dried him, and pulled the blankets up again, and Mina went and changed the water and brought more. They did it three times. Mina, who had not been inside a church since his confirmation, stood in the bedroom door with the empty pot and watched with an expression that Bishoy would remember for a long time afterward.

Then Bishoy filled a glass with hot water and stirred into it a spoon of the black honey from the tin, which went down into the water in a dark thread and turned the glass the color of strong tea, and held it, and the Mo'alem sat up against the headboard with Mina's arm behind him and drank it in small swallows with both hands around the glass.

The shaking came once more while he was drinking, and he waited it out, and drank again. Then it did not come. They sat and waited for it, the two boys, the way you wait for thunder after lightning, and it did not come. The Mo'alem gave Bishoy the empty glass. His color had changed. He said the black honey was from Nag Hammadi, he could taste it, the mills there boiled it longer than the others. Then he lay down on his side and slept for four hours without moving, and Mina sat in the kitchen beside the camp stove with his coat on, feeding it cans of butane from Bà Sáu's box, and Bishoy sat on the floor of the bedroom with his back against the wall, and toward evening, when it was dark and very cold, he heard the Mo'alem singing, very quietly, under the blankets, the first lines of the Midnight Praise, though it was nowhere near midnight. *Arise, O children of the light.* Bishoy did not know whether he was awake. He sang the responses anyway, as low as he could.

The power came back to Pipeline Road on Thursday morning. The Mo'alem was in church on Sunday, in the one coat he had kept, with his hand on Bishoy's shoulder.

V. The Question

Pipeline Road · the Saturday after

Dr. Nabil came to the apartment on the Saturday after the thaw, in the afternoon, when the Saturday class was over and the Mo'alem had been walked home. He brought nothing. He had thought for a long time about what to bring and had decided that the Mo'alem would only give it to a boy. He climbed the stair slowly with his hand on the rail, and it rang under his feet.

The Mo'alem knew him before he knocked.

They sat in the two chairs by the window. The room was warm again and smelled of Bà Sáu's rice soup and of the radiator. Nabil asked about his health, and was told, and asked about his stomach, and was told it was a stomach again, thanks be to God and to Dr. Nabil's water heater, and they were quiet a while. Then Nabil said that he had a question he had been carrying around for a year and had not been able to put down.

It was about the building fund. He had given, he said, a great deal of money to the new church, and he would give more. He had given to the monasteries in Egypt, to the bishop's charities, to the orphans in Upper Egypt, to the family of every man in the parish who lost his job in the oil bust, and he did not say any of this as a boast, he said it as an accountant would read out a column. And he did not know whether any of it had been accepted. He had prayed and he had given and he had given and he had prayed, and he was seventy-one, and in a dark house on Tuesday with the gas burning on the stove he had found he could not answer the question that a child could answer. He said it in Arabic, formally, the way he would have put a question to a bishop.

Mo'alem. To whom should a man give? To whom is a gift given, so that it bears fruit? How does a man make an offering that God will receive?

The Mo'alem turned his face toward the window, where the light was. He was smiling a little.

Doctor, he said, *you know it already. You have read it to us yourself, from the Gospel, standing at the lectern.* And he said it, not as a teacher says a thing

but as a cantor gives the first line for the boys to take up, so that Nabil heard his own voice come in after it.

> *He that receiveth a prophet in the name of a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward: and he that receiveth a righteous man in the name of a righteous man shall receive a righteous man's reward. And whosoever shall give to drink unto one of these little ones a cup of cold water only, in the name of a disciple, verily I say unto you he shall in no wise lose his reward.*
>
> *— Matthew 10:41–42*

It is the one who receives it, he said. *Not the size of the cup. You gave hot water,* he added, *so perhaps a little more.*

Nabil did not laugh. He asked, then, the question under the question, which was how a man was to know which one was the righteous man, the prophet, the disciple. Whether it was the new church with the dome, or the monastery, or the orphans, or the priest, or the bishop. How a man was supposed to know where to set the cup down.

The Mo'alem said that every morning of his life, before it was light, Dr. Nabil had said the psalms of the First Hour out of the Agpeya, and so had he, since he was a boy, and that the answer was in the First Hour, a few psalms in, and they could say it together if Dr. Nabil liked. And they did, the old blind man and the old geologist in the two chairs, in Arabic, from memory, and Bishoy, who had come back up the stair for the Mo'alem's cymbals and was standing in the door, heard it in the English of his own Agpeya in his head while they said it.

> *O Lord, who shall sojourn in thy tabernacle? and who shall dwell in thy holy mountain? He that walks blameless, and works righteousness, who speaks truth in his heart.*
>
> *He that does these things shall never be moved.*
>
> *— Psalm 14:1–2, 5 (Septuagint)*

When they had finished Nabil sat with his hands on his knees.

You sang with me once, the Mo'alem said. *In Shubra, at the church of the Virgin, in nineteen fifty-nine. You were nine years old. You had a good voice and you came in too early on every line, because you wanted to be first. Your father was a pharmacist on Shubra Street and stood at the back by the pillar on the left. You had a cough that winter.*

Nabil looked at him. He had not sung in a choir since he was twelve years old. He had never told anybody in Texas about the church of the Virgin in Shubra, or the pharmacy, or the pillar.

I remember all of them, said the Mo'alem. *Every voice. Where they stood. The ones who are in heaven now and the ones who aren't yet.* He put his hand out, and found Nabil's knee, and patted it twice. *You still come in early.*

VI. The Back Row

The fellowship hall · Lent, 2021

The building committee met the following week, on Zoom, and Dr. Nabil Habashy proposed that a part of the fund, a large part, be set aside before anything was poured for the dome, for the parishioners who had come out of the freeze with burst pipes and no insurance, and for the apartment complex behind the tire shop on Pipeline Road, where the water had come through three ceilings, and for whatever else the Mo'alem might point at, though the Mo'alem had not pointed at anything and would not. There was an argument. He won it. He was used to winning arguments, and this time he did not enjoy it, and he noticed that.

Then he went to Abouna and asked to be made a member of the Saturday class.

Abouna thought he was joking. The Saturday class was for boys. Dr. Nabil was the chairman of the building committee and the oldest deacon in the parish by rank and knew more Coptic than the priest did. Dr. Nabil said that was true, and that he knew the words to every hymn in the book, and that he had not learned one of them properly since he was twelve years old, and that he would like to learn them now from the

Mo'alem, the old way, by ear, one line at a time, before one of them died, and he did not much mind which.

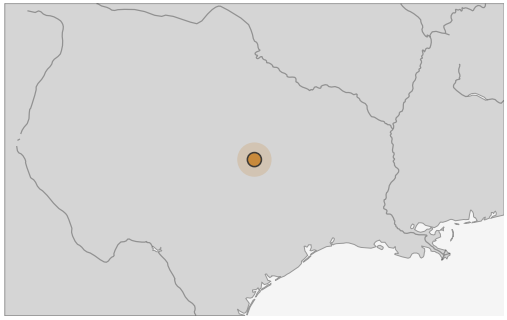
So on the first Saturday of the Great Fast there were thirteen chairs in the fellowship hall instead of twelve, set six feet apart, and in the back row among the boys in their masks, in a white tunic that had been ironed by his wife and was a little short in the sleeves, sat a seventy-one-year-old geologist with a pencil he had been told not to use. The Mo'alem sat at the front with the cymbals in his lap and gave the first line of the long Lenten hymn, and the boys took it up, and the old man in the back row came in half a beat too early, and the Mo'alem lifted one hand from the cymbals without turning his head, and held it there, open, in the air, until he waited.

Background

The verse

> *Him I call indeed a Brahmana who knows his former abodes, who sees heaven and hell, has reached the end of births, is perfect in knowledge, a sage, and whose perfections are all perfect.*
>
> Dhammapada 423, tr. F. Max Müller (1881)

In the commentary, the Buddha falls ill with a disorder of the humors and sends his attendant, the elder Upavāṇa, to the brahmin Devahita for hot water. Devahita is overjoyed to be asked. He gives hot water and a jar of molasses and has one of his men carry the water on a shoulder pole. The elder bathes the Buddha in the hot water and gives him the molasses mixed in water to drink, and the illness passes. Devahita then comes to the Buddha with a question in verse: to whom should one give, so that the gift bears great fruit? The Buddha answers that gifts to one who is truly a brahmin, the sage who knows his former lives, sees heaven and hell and has come to the end of birth, bear the greatest fruit, and Devahita takes refuge and becomes a lay disciple. Read the full commentary story.



Euless, Texas

North Texas, February 2021

In mid-February 2021 a run of winter storms, the worst of them named Uri, drove arctic air deep into Texas. Demand for power broke records while frozen gas supplies and unwinterized plants failed, and in the early hours of February 15 the state's grid operator began cutting power to keep the whole system from collapsing. More than 4.5 million homes and businesses lost power, some for days, in temperatures that reached −2 °F at Dallas/Fort Worth International Airport on February 16, the coldest in North Texas in seventy-two years. Pipes burst across the state and many people faced hypothermia in their own homes; the state later put the death toll at 246. See the 2021 Texas power crisis. Gas appliances with a standing pilot, which need no electricity, were for many families the only heat or hot water left.

The Coptic Orthodox Church of Egypt now has many parishes in American cities and suburbs, including in Dallas–Fort Worth. Its hymns, sung to hand cymbals and triangle, were handed down orally for centuries, and the parish cantor, the *mu'allim* or "teacher," taught them to the deacons by ear. Most cantors of the older generation were blind, since the blind were thought to have the finer ear; the most famous modern cantor, Mikhail Girgis El Batanouny (1873–1957), helped preserve the chants. Psalm 14 in the Greek numbering (15 in the Hebrew) is among the psalms of the First Hour of the Agpeya, the Coptic book of hours prayed each morning. The Mo'alem, Dr. Nabil, Bishoy, Bà Sáu and the church off Pipeline Road are invented.

After the story of the Brahmin Devahita from the Dhammapada commentary (verse 423). The original. Scripture from the American Standard Version and Brenton's translation of the Septuagint. Written by Claude Opus 5.5.